Deathly Beautiful

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/26039053.

Rating:	Explicit
Archive Warning:	Graphic Depictions Of Violence
Category:	M/M
Fandom:	僕のヒーローアカデミア | Boku no Hero Academia | My Hero Academia
Relationship:	Bakugou Katsuki/Midoriya Izuku
Characters:	Bakugou Katsuki, Midoriya Izuku, Aizawa Shouta | Eraserhead, Class 1-A (My Hero Academia), Class 1-B (My Hero Academia)
Additional Tags:	Alternate Universe - Assassins & Hitmen, Enemies to Lovers, Minor Character Death, They're killers your honor, Fake/Pretend Relationship, Fluff and Angst, Top Bakugou Katsuki, Bottom Midoriya Izuku, Angst and Hurt/Comfort, Character Death, Criminal Behavior, darker themes, Knife Play, Gun Violence, Violent Sexual Tension, Fuck Marry Kill taken literally, Attempt at Humor, Angst with a Happy Ending, Heavy Angst, Happy Ending
Language:	English
Collections:	My Hero Academia Favorite Fics, BKDK to Reread Again and Again, These are Bundles of Emotions (and I Love them af), Adored Fics, Cel's fav bkdk fics, BKDK fics that both broke and healed my soul 🧡💚, Bakudeku Fics That Ripped My Heart Out And Made Me Question Existence, twin stars ♡, Stellar Fics: A Wonder Duo Collection ☆★, retro-triscuit's favorite (bkdkbk) fics
Stats:	Published: 2020-08-22 Completed: 2025-12-12 Words: 888,031 Chapters: 53/53

Deathly Beautiful

by KyuukaKoinu

Summary

Katsuki always believed the first emotion he felt about the mysterious man was anger. Unchecked, pure fucking resentment. He thought the bitter emotion coursed through him like a raging river and struck lightning on every nerve he had.

But when he truly thought back on it—the first emotion he felt wasn’t anger. It wasn't even hate or mild dislike.

It was morbid curiosity.

Notes

My Twitter
Deathly Beautiful Spotify Playlist

See the end of the work for more notes

Chapter 1: Da Capo

Chapter Notes

Hello! :D I come barring a fic that's been sitting in my WIP for a couple months as an outline. I'm really excited to write this one. ^^

This fic is Beta'd by the moon of my life, LunaToons on AO3 :) Enjoy!

I do not allow reposts or translations on Wattpad. If you're going to do a translation, please do so on AO3. Thank you.

Update note:

This turned out to be a monster ever bigger than I would have imagined. But I had a TON of fun doing it and I loved every second. If you want to start this fic but are intimated by the word count, that's totally understandable!

Something that helped me push through writing was breaking this down in chunks. This fic is essentially four "books" in one. If you want to pace yourself that way you can!

Part I: The Scarlet Eyed Killer (270k words) Chapters 1 - 16.
Part II: The Viridian Viper (190k words) Chapters 17 - 26.
Part III: The Dance (178k words) Chapters 27 - 37.
Part IV: The Lovebirds (246k) Chapters 38 - 53.

<3 I hope you enjoy the journey!

See the end of the chapter for more notes



Chapter one — Da Capo

.

.

.

Katsuki knew it was going to be a shit assignment when Denki spilled coffee on his dress shirt right after he got the folder. He should've fucking guessed something was wrong the moment all the stars began misaligning for him.

First off, the mission itself was absolutely trash. He knew it the second he was handed that godforsaken dark green folder. The red wax emblem sealing it was practically taunting him. When he tore it open, just as he suspected, it was vanilla as fuck. He skimmed for the yellow highlighted details and he snorted out loud.

He had to be *a bodyguard*.

Katsuki was more than well equipped to be something other than a goddamn bodyguard. His track record and portfolio included a lot more high profile type of jobs but at this point in his career, he'd take what he could get.

His last green folder assignment was mildly compromised because he let his temper flare out of control and mouthed off to the wrong people. Now this was his punishment—working this shit green folder jobs until he could prove that he was able to keep his temper under control.

The Company dispatched him that same night with his equipment on a private jet. His leather suitcase was filled with several guns, tasers, and knives—the usual go to things. He kept in an annoyed grunt when his boss, Aizawa Shouta, gave him that look™ before he was sent off.

"Don't mess this up, Bakugou," his supervisor's voice dragged out. His eyebrow twitched several times while staring at him. "We really need to make sure this client is happy if we want to ensure future relationships with his connections."

"Yeah yeah, I got it old man," Katsuki grumbled underneath his breath while he casually spun his favorite stainless blade in his fingers. "You know damn well I'll make sure whatever crooked bastard is safe."

"I don't think we're in the right business to be calling anyone crooked, but that's the right mindset. Don't fuck this up for us. I mean it—keep that hot headed temper of yours under control this time."

Katsuki nodded reluctantly while maintaining eye contact with Aizawa's bloodshot eyes. He put his blade away while he resisted the deeply strong urge to roll his eyes. His boss was so clearly sleep deprived—*yet again*. It made Katsuki wonder if there was ever a day where the damn man *wasn't* tired?

He was handed a small list of people's names he needed to memorize on the sixteen hour flight to Madrid along with all their pictures. Everyone on the list he was meant to protect was extremely serious looking with sharp eyes and frowns. The head boss who he was assigned to watch over was the most serious looking of them all.

Mr. Aguado.

He had dark honey brown eyes and exactly three forehead creases across his fair skin. His midnight black hair was streaked with dark grey hairs that congregated in the front and the deep, grotesque scar gashed above his left eye hinted at an unknown story. Katsuki filled in a blank in his mind: whoever gave him that nasty mark, Katsuki was sure wasn't alive.

The details of the mission were simple and straightforward: he had to be Mr. Aguado's bodyguard for a single night. His job was to keep everything peaceful as the 'business' leader negotiated over underground poker games in Madrid at one of his sketchy private clubs.

There were no other details and truthfully, Katsuki didn't want or need them. Whatever this man did was his business and at the end of the day Katsuki only wanted to get paid so he could hit his contract's quota and possibly get the hell out of this lifestyle.

His 26th birthday was nearing and Katsuki was admittedly damn tired.

He had signed up for this career when he was a poor, homeless teenager knowing that it would trap him for a total of ten years. Originally, all he cared about was the lucrative income because he thought this was something that he wanted. The excitement that came with danger and crime was addictive and he was no stranger to the burden of murder at a young age.

He had a lot to give to The Company because he never once batted an eye at the under the table commands that were coupled with a loaded sniper gun and black ski mask. He did what he was told and he did it efficiently so that he could go home later that night with a large amount of yen transferred into his bank account.

But in the past five years, a lot changed.

The more blood that was spilled by his hands, it stayed washed over him like an invisible layer that never truly vanished. Especially with what had happened when he was twenty. His whole universe warped, shifting to a dull black and white view of the world and all the color in it was stolen away from him.

After that, every work day felt like a chore. Living was significantly harder for him. Killing became less of a passion and more of a reluctant pass time that kept his pockets padded. It was as if the blood he spilled on himself was permanently stained against his skin whether he liked it or not and he found himself numbing his emotions whenever he was given a new red folder.

Red always meant the job ended in lethality. Green meant protecting a mark with minimal casualties. Yellow was a mix of both and a wild card.

But with his skill set, he was almost *always* exclusively given red folders that matched the same color of his eyes. Many of his fellow colleagues gave him the nickname 'The Scarlet Eyed Killer' because of how many bodies were under his belt by the time he was twenty years old.

At that time, the body count was exactly four times his age but now, five years later, it had exponentially increased—along with his kill shot accuracy. He was rivaled by no one in The Company and now his reputation far past preceded him in their internal affairs. He had only ever met one other person who came close to the same amount of skills as him—

—but he wasn't about to think about that goddamn *nuisance*.

A flash of bright green eyes and a taunting smile on pink lips appeared in his mind.

Katsuki felt his jaw automatically clench painfully at the thought of that strangely strong short bastard who had been a certified thorn in his ass for nearly a *decade*. He heavily huffed when he realized just thinking about that personification of an inconvenience made his fucking body tense.

But he concluded he was on his way to Madrid, *Spain* and his muscles relaxed slowly.

There was no fucking way he would have another run in with him there—the chance were slim. *Ultra* slim. From what he gathered, whoever the damn guy was, he operated mainly in Japan and he's only ever run into him out of the country three times within the last eight years that they knew each other—or—er, knew *of* each other.

Katsuki ground his teeth together and tried to wash away the feeling of freckles trickling into his thoughts.

By the time nightfall came, Katsuki laid in the small bed silently staring up at the plain cream colored roof of the jet. He pulled out his stainless blade that he's had with him ever since he started this career and stared at it emptily.

The handle fit perfectly in his large, calloused hand and the blade was short enough to deliver swift, lethal blows without being too noticeable by whoever he was up against. The ends of the handle were carefully trimmed in gold and on one side of black handle his name was choppily engraved on it and the other side, his mother's.

His dark red eyes studied the reflection of himself through the metal of his blade pensively.

He noted the dark bags under his eyes, the semi-permanent frown on his lips and how his light blond hair was tousled slightly against the plain colored pillow underneath his head. He turned his head slightly to get a better look at his strong jawline and his brows pinched together.

He looked just like her now—undeniably so. If someone was to stop him on the streets in Tokyo and ask if he was 'Mitsuki's boy' he wouldn't even deny it because it'd be so stupid to even try deflecting. His mind briefly wondered if his own reflection is what really kept him going these last five years or if it was the reason why he was feeling burnt out now.

A weight inside of Katsuki's chest suddenly appeared at the thought of his mother and instantly tripled when the sour memory of her bloodied body pushed forward to the front of his mind. The young adult shook his head softly and re-sleeved his blade before turning over and closing his eyes.

He had to focus on his assignment.

☽ ☽ ☽

When his jet landed at the private air station in Spain he was greeted by Mr. Aguado's pointed smile.

The corners of the man's lips stretched from ear to ear and a deep, delighted chuckle bubbled up from his chest. The man was larger than he expected and came up to nearly meet Katsuki's 6'3" height. Mr. Aguado's greedy smile looked beyond grateful that he was here and he gripped Katsuki's shoulders simultaneously securely and threateningly with excitement.

"I'm thrilled that I can have you join us tonight, Mr. Bakugou!" Mr. Aguado greeted as he proudly clasped Katsuki's right hand in between his two. Sharp red eyes darted down to see all the different expensive gold and silver rings decorating the elder man's hands.

Yup. There it fucking was.

That was the distinctive hint that Mr. Aquado was a crime lord of sorts.

Katsuki held back a scowl as he gripped the handshake tighter. He felt himself grow downright exhausted when he realized that he might end up killing someone within the next couple hours whether he wanted to or not. Shit with crime lords was *always* sloppy. He preferred the politicians or world leaders who requested his services much more.

"I'm glad to be of service," Katsuki replied in a curt tone as he eyed the other two large bodyguards. "I'll make sure nothing happens to you while you're doing your negotiations."

"I have no doubts you'll be fucking amazing," the elder man laughed heartily. "I took a close look at your portfolio before we came and I must say, the job you did in Vienna several years ago had me *sold* on you. You're definitely the right person for this job."

Katsuki resisted rolling his eyes and kept his plastic smile plastered across his face to the point he nearly gagged. Vienna was a nightmare in reality but on paper it was fine—no one knew what had actually occurred.

It *unfortunately* was where he met that broccoli looking motherfucker.

Whenever he thought of his old Vienna assignment he got *so* immensely pissed off. And he thought about it *every damn day* thanks to the bullet three scars in his left bicep he had to look at every time he showered. The son of a bitch had near perfect aim with a gun.

The conversation transitioned easily as Aguado's men took his things and Katsuki was briefed on what would be happening. Aguado had several intensely important deals to make

starting at 23:00 sharp with rather high profile people in a sketchy underground that was controlled by his partner. Katsuki's job was to make sure no one who might think Mr. Aguado would look better with a bullet in his chest actually succeeded in doing so.

From the gist of what Katsuki was getting—it seemed like there were a lot of people who wanted to see Aguado pumped full of lead. But he didn't think too hard about it. When he was given that green folder in the Japan headquarters, he knew what it meant: as little casualties as possible to make sure no attention was brought to them.

His shift started immediately and soon he found himself walking towards a crowded club called 'The Sapphire' and it was overflowing with expensive looking people. Blue, purple and pink neon colors lined the night club and there was a strict dress code everyone had to adhere to that seemed to be cool colors only.

When they walked in all the way, effectively cutting the line wrapping around the building, Katsuki's eyebrows raised up in surprise. *Well goddamn* he thought to himself as his hand adjusted his blade into the secret pocket inside his blazer.

Overall the place was higher class than Katsuki anticipated and he was happy he'd packed his better-looking clothes for this assignment. He had changed into an all neatly tailored black suit with a jet-black silk dress shirt to go underneath his blazer and his golden stud earring to match his watch.

The ceiling of the club was black, blue with decorative gold etchings of various patterns. Waiters and waitresses were bustling around with blue bowties, white dress shirts and black vests, the club's uniform Katsuki put together. The music inside was medium noise where he could still hear the two other guards next to him chatter but the deep vibrations emitting from the speakers rumbled through him.

The smell of gin and whiskey assaulted his senses and he scrunched his nose up when they entered into the V.I.P section of the club. It was sectioned off by red rope and attractive men and women were casually seated all around fawning over the several powerful looking people gathered around the poker table.

Red eyes glanced over the dense crowd as he stood behind Aguado like a dutiful soldier with his hands neatly placed in front of him. The two other bodyguards stood next to him on either side as the next seated at the table began their coded conversation and Katsuki tuned out completely and just focused on the music.

☽ ☽ ☽

Time melted away to be nearly 02:00 and at this point Katsuki was bored out of his fucking mind. Not a single sign of something suspicious happened besides some questionable ass comments from Mr. Aquado about paying the female waitress to come by his place later for some after dark *'fun.'*

Katsuki scoffed out loud at that one, unable to hide his attitude.

He kept his eyes focused the entire time on the crowd and dipping in and out of the conversation the other two men in all black were having. His annoyance began to flare when he realized this was just another dead job. These were just a bunch of extras. Extras all around him talking about useless shit, *doing* useless shit and he was in the middle of it, guarding a useless piece of shit when he could be out trying to find the person who killed—

“Wow, Bakugou, take a look,” the man next to him whispered as he elbowed him in the side. “That waiter has a perfect ass on him, goddamn. You don’t see that type of perky backside often.”

The other bodyguard quickly followed the line of vision and gave a low whistle in agreeance.

Katsuki groaned internally in frustration because nothing had happened so far and now he was making goddamn small talk with some extra about *another* extra’s ass.

...However...

Katsuki clicked his tongue and huffed because he was an ass man at the end of the day. Cutthroat crimson eyes turned to the guy next to him because, why the hell not?

“Where at?” He asked in a slightly curious tone that curled up at the end.

He skimmed the crowd for this so this so-called ‘perfect-ass’ just so he could be the judge of that. Giving such a claim was rather bold because he can only really ever recall a single person to really have what he would deem as the world’s most ‘perfect ass.’ No matter how annoying the little shit was.

“Black pinstripe pants and vest on the left, he’s the one facing away from us, he has the tray with the sapphire martinis on it.”

Katsuki trailed his gaze to look for wherever this waiter was. He skimmed until he saw the silver tray holding unnaturally colored blue drinks in the dim lighting.

But when his eyes sank below the belt to check out the man, everything spun into slow motion. His stomach knotted, throat felt like it was stuffed to the brim with dry cotton and his eyes shot all the way open with a sudden rush of adrenaline.

There’s no fucking way—

All of his senses spiraled into overdrive because he only knew *one* person with an ass stacked like that.

When the waiter turned around fully, dark curls bounced with the motion and Katsuki hated the fact he was fucking *right*. Those sharp as daggers emerald eyes locked onto the V.I.P section and under the flashing blue and purple neon lights, a look of surprise painted the other man’s soft features when they both locked gazes.

Then within the next millisecond, that look of lethality Katsuki had repeatedly witnessed gripped that cursed freckled face.

Fuck.

“Get down!” Katsuki snatched his gun out of his holster and grabbed Mr. Aguado quicker than anyone could think.

“W-What? What’s happening—” but the crime leader’s question was cut short by his own blood curdling scream as a bullet landed square in his right kneecap.

Katsuki cursed himself as they all quickly scrambled for cover in the blindsiding chaos. Several expertly aimed bullets whizzed unnervingly close to Katsuki’s ear and his heart rate tripled in speed at the sudden urgency. He was certain he just *barely* fucking ducked in enough time and could feel several fine hairs sliced right off his head by bullets.

Katsuki quickly reached up to flip the poker table on its side to use as a shield as the bullets rained down. He ignored the loud fall of colorful poker chips and how the cards spilled into the air like confetti. The gunshots rang out and screams filled the club’s space as party goers began shoving and running quickly.

Katsuki cursed loudly when he took a risk to look from above the table only to be met with a bullet that grazed straight over his skin leaving behind a boiling hot trail, skinning him slightly. He bit down on the inside of his cheek as he took cover again and hovered above his mark before rage started to steam underneath his skin.

That son of a bitch is not going to blow this job for me.

Katsuki’s nostrils flared wildly as his scowl broke free from his emotionless mask. He turned his eyes towards the other two assigned bodyguards as he loaded his spare guns without looking.

“You two get Mr. Aguado to the car and to the safe room at the hotel for medical attention,” he instructed in a tone that left no room for anyone to object. “I’m going to go neutralize this fucking *pest*.” He hissed the last word before carefully rolling out from under his cover when he counted the last of the bullet in the round from the second gun.

He quickly spotted the head of dark green curls that was quickly retreating through the thinning crowd at high speed and Katsuki yelled and took off at full speed through pushing people out of the way and jumping over the tables that were knocked over in his way.

“I’m going to fucking *murder* you, Deku!” He screamed full of absolute rage.

“Owch, still using that nickname?” The breathy voice answered and Katsuki groaned at how innocent he sounded. “You’ve never been the creative one.”

The nameless man he had been bumping into for *years* picked up the speed as he tossed whatever vase, table, or chair at Katsuki in hopes of derailing him. But the hot-tempered blond blazed through it with sharp reflexes because today was the fucking day. He was going to shove his foot so far up that small fry’s ass—

The green eyed agent looked over his shoulder and Katsuki saw red. The fucking short stack *winked* at him before sharply turning down an abandoned back hallway in the club.

He hated how familiar this felt—it was almost a goddamn routine now.

But it was a routine he was about to dead end because there was no way he was going to let this mission get screwed up. Katsuki came to a skidding halt when both he and that damn Deku realized there was no else to run. Katsuki heard the freckled man curse when he closed one eye and took a skilled shot at the green eyed nuisance in front of him.

But of course—Deku moved swiftly as if he was made of water.

“Fuck!” Katsuki yelled out and fired off several more rounds in hopes of landing one.

He could feel his temper beginning to rise in a way that only this guy could pressure out of him. The blond gritted his teeth in annoyance because this happened every damn time. The other’s short height gave him an advantage on moving quicker but Katsuki’s strength still gave him enough advantage as well.

Now they were in the same position they always were in: a stalemate.

The two were now face to face sharply dodging blows and blocking punches, kicks, and bullets. Slowly but surely, all the professionalism inside of Katsuki’s body was flying out the damn window along with his patience.

“I cannot believe you followed me to *Spain* you fucking green stain!” Katsuki yelled out, absolutely livid. “I’m starting to think you’ve got some sick crush on me or some shit, you little *stalker*!”

He swiped his leg underneath the other who fell to the ground with a sharp thud and yell. Katsuki’s blood red eyes narrowed in on the pale neck that was exposed as he drew his blade from his belt quickly. With all his strength he hurled forward to take a blow for the neck, but the smaller man rolled quicker than he could land the attack and he unsuccessfully stabbed his lethal blow into the wooden floorboards.

Katsuki wildly whirled his head around and was met with a swift brutal kick to the face that had him clutching his nose in agony.

“Please, don’t flatter yourself!” Fucking *Deku* yelled back, green eyes resentful and face flushed...*pink*? Katsuki squinted his eyes in disbelief when he thought he was hallucinating. Was this guy actually fucking *blushing*?

“Y-You—You’re guarding my mark like *always* and you’re in my way again! Now stay out of my sight, I have a job to do—*ah*!” Deku’s sentence was cut short the moment he tried to turn around and Katsuki grabbed him in a tight choker hold by the neck.

“Oh, you’re not going anywhere,” Katsuki rebutted through a low rasp and began to reach for his gun. He shook the other man furiously when the shorter man tried to get out of his hold.

“I’m going to put a goddamn bullet in your skull for good this time. I’m so goddamn sick of you—”

Before he could finish, his world view toppled backwards at an alarming speed. He gave a loud grunt as he was slammed backwards onto the hard ground. Katsuki cursed loudly when he heard something in his back brutally *crack*. He squeezed his eyes closed for a half of a moment to regain his senses but when he reopened them he froze.

The smaller man had broken free of his hold, twisted himself around to straddle him and pressed a sharp knife directly against his jugular.

Shit—

Frigid ice trickled into his veins and he stayed deathly still waiting for the other to move his hand and slice him open. He flinched his head to the side at the expected movement—but was met with...nothing?

A moment too long for any expert agent to stay paused passed and Katsuki looked up. His brow furrowed. His eyes traveled up confused only to be met with deep forest green eyes that held immense conflict. Conflict that he’s never seen the other man have.

He should be *dead* right now—bleeding out on the ground applying hopeless pressure to his neck as blood spurted out. But he wasn’t.

Instead he could feel all the details about the intimacy of their position pressed against him. Warm breath. The hand gripping his wrist. The soft curls resting against his forehead. But most of all he noted the surprising delicate facial features of this man he had only ever encountered when bullets were being shot at him.

This close up, Katsuki saw the different shades of freckles sprinkled across the other’s nose. Light brown, dark brown or soft like mocha. Some were almost invisible, nearly blended into ivory like skin and would be totally unnoticeable if not for how close they were—

He was ripped violently from his thoughts when the knife against his skin pressed in further and Katsuki hissed when he could feel blood drawn. The delicate face twisted into a conflict snarl.

“Stay the hell out of my way,” the soft voice warned in a tone that sounded forced. As if he didn’t want to be pushed into doing something he didn’t want to.

Katsuki glowered sourly before he could control himself.

“What the *fuck* is your prob—shit!” He yelled when suddenly the knife pressed against his throat jerked violently, ripping through his skin—*shallowly*.

A swift right hook landed square on his jaw causing him to bite his tongue and the bitter taste of iron filled his mouth. The other man pushed off of him at the sound of police sirens and was high tailing it quicker than Katsuki could recover from the devastating blow to his face.

Ignoring the burning pounding of his head, the blond sat forward quickly and turned around to see the retreating back side of the other. Deku ran quickly into the stampede of the crowd in the dim lights, dodging anyone in his way as if he was on fire.

Oh no you fucking don't— Katsuki snatched his second gun out of his holster and aimed it perfectly for the other's head. He closed one eye and took a deep breath, and as if he could feel him aim at him, the nameless man turned his head slightly to stare Katsuki directly in the eye.

The sight of those unique green eyes made Katsuki's heart skip a beat instead of his finger pulling the trigger.

Everything sped up again and, in a flash, the other disappeared right out of his life—*again*.

Katsuki cursed as he spat out the blood rushing into his mouth and lowered his gun slowly. When the head of curls were completely out of sight, the confused assassin idly touched the small bit of blood on his neck.

The cut was so precisely shallow that it had to be a warning and not a miscalculation. He didn't cut deep on purpose. Confusion tousled around inside his chest.

Why didn't he kill me…?

☽ ☽ ☽

"You fucking blew it, Bakugou," Aizawa said in the most disappointed voice he's ever heard him use. "How in the *hell* did you let the mark you were supposed to *protect* get shot? In the kneecap of all places on top of it? He's nowhere near happy with us and is asking for a full refund because you didn't even bring in the assailant."

Katsuki slid down in the uncomfortable chair in the Japan headquarters.

He was currently in Aizawa's boring looking office getting harshly reprimanded. He could barely lift his eyes up to meet the infuriated gaze of his superior across the table because he was beyond pissed. Katsuki was beating himself up greatly and it was all because of that headache of a man.

"I told you, it was the other agent who got in the way—*again*!" Katsuki barked back loudly. "That green eyed, green hair minty smelling motherfucker. The one who killed Rin Hiryu."

Aizawa gave a lengthy groan and glanced up at the ceiling as if he was praying for eternal sleep.

Katsuki frowned so hard he was certain his face would get stuck like it. He was so goddamn *screwed*.

After Mr. Aguado got done chewing his head off, he then went to his higher ups inside The Company and chewed their ears off. Mr. Aguado wanted blood after his kneecap was shattered, but Katsuki had failed to return to the checkpoint with the person who shot at them

despite making the promise to ‘terminate the pest.’ Now he was wishing he’d used better language.

Why the fuck did he always make snap promises out loud?

“Is this the guy you keep running into?” Aizawa asked as he slid a small photograph across the table.

Katsuki finally peeled his eyes off his hands in his lap to the wooden surface in front of him. There he saw a small, old photograph of that man in a loose white tee shirt that was slung off his shoulder. His eyebrows raised up surprised because it looked as if it was taken in his teen years and his eyes were lifeless. Completely void of emotions and dull.

Extremely opposite of whenever they were locked on Katsuki himself.

“Yeah, that’s the brat,” he grumbled unhappily.

He picked up the photograph and squinted his eyes when he noticed a small tattoo directly beneath the man’s freckled clavicle on his exposed shoulder.

217.

Katsuki’s eyebrows pinched together.

Aizawa let out the most exhausted sigh Katsuki ever witnessed and rubbed his temple. “Well, that makes sense as to why he’s been giving you trouble then. And it explains why he’s always trying to kill the mark when you’re on a green folder assignment.”

“Wait, you *know* him?” Katsuki said, voice slightly raised. His skin bristled a bit because it’s been eight fucking years since he first reported this guy and they were just getting answers *now*? “Why didn’t you let me know when I’ve been fucking tell you about him this whole time?”

“I didn’t know, and I only recently started getting a lead after digging around,” Aizawa snapped back with a fierce glare. “I got this photograph from a source that was very, *very* hard to make cooperate and is now dead because of our negotiations. If this really is the guy you’ve been running into, then it’s safe to say he’s just working for another agency in Japan, a far deadlier one that is a lot less flexible than we are.”

Katsuki’s upper lip curled. “What does that mean?”

“It means he works for an exclusively red folder operation.”

Oh.

“Next time you see him, you kill him on sight,” Aizawa said in a curt tone.

“What the hell do you think I’ve been trying to do?” Katsuki mumbled emptily. “He’s more slippery than he looks.”

He subconsciously touched the shallow cut along his neck.

The pads of his fingers traced the tiny hills of the straight-line scab and couldn't help but wonder why the hell hadn't the guy taken the kill? The opportunity was right there, and it was the only one he had ever gotten in the eight years they spent shooting bullets and throwing knives at each other. Well, outside of the first time they met.

He thought back to the intense conflict he saw blaze in those green eyes when the knife was pressed against his neck.

"I know, but I'm just officially giving the order since we now can confirm it's him. We don't know his name or who he works for, but if he's a constant problem then he has to go. We can't afford to keep blowing the green folder missions we get since our company is almost exclusively green."

Katsuki bit his tongue to hold back a quip.

Exclusively green my ass. Even if that were true, he was never given quite the same balance. He saw red folder after red folder with just a sprinkle of green. He looked down at the photograph in his fingertips.

Well...a lot of green. Sometimes.

"What does this number tattooed on him mean?" Katsuki muttered under his breath. "Is it a date?"

"Not a clue," Aizawa said in a short tone. He reached forward and snatched the tiny photograph back and neatly tucked it away in his blazer. Katsuki frowned and opened his mouth to object but was cut down immediately. "Instead of fantasizing about your enemy's tattoos, you *should* be worrying about your own job. Two fucked up assignments in a row are never good, Bakugou."

Katsuki sighed and carded a hand through his messy spikes. He was so goddamn *tired*. He briefly mulled if this new tiredness in him would ever go away and he would return to his old self: a well-oiled killing machine. But it seemed like every passing day just added a new weight to his person. It felt as though the invisible shackles on his ankles were getting longer.

After this Madrid assignment he felt more solidified in a decision he had been going back and forth on. He knew he wasn't in a case of burn out anymore. He was done.

Katsuki's mind unwillingly wandered back to his mother's body cold, lifeless and covered in blood again.

"...I want to retire soon, whenever I fill my assignment quota," Katsuki whispered, hanging his head away to avoid whatever look Aizawa would have given him. "I've reached the ten year threshold on my contract last week and I don't think I'm going to be signing on again. I think my time is done."

His boss leaned back and Katsuki was wholeheartedly surprised to be met with silence. He was at least expecting a sarcastic snip or some backhanded ass comment about his ridiculous request to tap out in his mid-twenties.

Instead, they just waded in a wordless exchange. He listened to the clicking of the ceiling fan and the footsteps outside the door bustling about as his boss said nothing.

“I had a feeling,” Aizawa eventually said in a soft voice. He strummed his fingers against the wooden desk accompanied by a thoughtful look. The higher ranked agent turned his head to look out the large window of his office in the high-rise building.

Katsuki’s eyes followed the trail and he looked over the colorful city of Tokyo in a distant manner. He didn’t feel attached to it anymore. Not like he used to.

“I’ve been waiting on this conversation, but I was hoping it would come after a successful mission and you could transition out smoother.” Aizawa rolled his neck as he reached underneath the desk and pulled out a red folder. Katsuki held back a sigh. “Your quota is one assignment short; this mission should’ve been your last but that’s not the case. The higher ups need a successful job out of you before your contract is one hundred percent complete. If you successfully follow this one through, then you’re set to go.”

The folder was slid across to him and Katsuki ignored the grogginess that filled his core. He focused on the positive because, this was his last mission thank fucking god. Piercing red eyes studied the black wax emblem that was imprinted with the symbol of death in kanji.

“I figured a red assignment would be easier for you to complete after you botched two green assignments in a row.”

Katsuki shrugged in response to that statement because his boss wasn’t wrong.

“I’ll see you in eight days, Bakugou. Hopefully it’ll be to give you a new identity and passport and not to reprimand you for fucking up again.”

“See you in a week old man.”

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki made a mental note to give Aizawa a fucking hug next time he saw him.

This last assignment was going to be a piece of cake. Delicious fucking cake that Katsuki was going to devour in less than eight days. He didn’t even need eight days to complete it, he had this shit in the bag and would be done in three days tops.

His supervisor had somehow pulled strings to get him this sweet deal of a last mission and it was a perfect send off. It was domestic, no long ass flights involved, and to add the cherry on top: it was in Nago, Okinawa. Beautiful, tropical Okinawa with clear waters, turtles, and beaches.

Hell, when all this was over, Katsuki might even kick his feet up for the remaining four days and just fucking take a well deserved vacation while in the area.

His mark was some sleaze bag which made the assignment that much easier. According to the file, the guy, who was named Peter Moore, was the head of an underground human trafficking organization branch. He had spent years escaping the laws in the U.K, United States and South America. He had a bounty on his head and now he was settled in Japan under a false name of Henry Sekai, passing as a half Caucasian half Japanese humble hotel owner. However, the hotel was an elaborate cover up for the human trafficking.

The theme of the hotel was an extremely discreet couples' getaway set up. The name was the corniest thing Katsuki had ever witnessed in his near twenty six years of life. *Ai no Rakuen*. Love's Paradise.

Katsuki scoffed several times reading the itinerary for this place because, holy hell, it was fucking cheesy.

Couples' messages? Pool side mingling? Beach picnics and romantic hiking? *Blegh*.

Katsuki scrunched his nose up in disgust as he looked at all the pink and red glitter hearts printed in the pamphlet. Who the hell falls for this shit? He hated romantic propaganda with a passion, it was so goddamn pointless to him. Just a mindless way to brainwash the masses into buying products they don't need for temporary people in their lives.

He would rather shove flowers in a garbage disposal than give them to someone.

When his jet landed he took a taxi straight for the hotel and it was packed tighter than the club in Madrid.

Katsuki gave a long, heavy huff through his nose at the visual of nearly every damn person coupled up. It was disgusting. Appalling. Stomach retching and he feared losing his lunch just staring at all these extras. He hated the way they were completely lovey dovey. If he squinted, he wouldn't be surprised if he saw heart eyes and or some shit sparkling in their eyes like a shoujo anime. There were even a few singles who looked like they were already scouting out their next hopeless infatuation.

I guess this place is more popular than we thought he noted mentally when it seemed like Ai no Rakuen was the hottest new spot in town. He put the pieces together that the increased popularity also meant it would be easier for Peter Moore's men to possibly kidnap someone.

He waited patiently in line adjusting his short sleeved black tank top and pulled his designer sunglasses over his eyes. His frown was permanently in place as he listened to one married couple bicker but kept a straight face and remembered his persona for this assignment.

He was single, ready to mingle slash murder or whatever and then leave as soon as possible.

He dragged his black suitcase behind him as he walked up to the second line at the counter. He glanced around at the packed lobby and took his place behind a rather short man wearing a colorful sunhat. The entire setting was as if the United States' tacky ass Valentine's day and White Day had a really furious love child.

The architecture of the building was pure, unstained white with decorations of glitter, pastel hearts and expensive flat screens on the wall of the lobby playing some romantic looking movie. Katsuki nearly gagged when the male lead dipped the female lead low and whispered in her ear.

Red eyes quickly averted away from that disgusting display of commercialized affection to stare in front of him. What the hell was taking so long? He was second in line and the line should be moving quicker than it was. He grumbled and tried to peer over at the check in counter.

Katsuki leaned forward to look past the large straw sun hat decorated in purple flowers that was nearly blocking his view. He was met with the sight of an empty station and groaned loudly, drawing the attention of several people nearby.

Right as he was in the middle of weighing if this was worth it his eyes naturally trailed down to the figure in front of him and he froze. He blinked once. Then blinked again and his hand snapped up to whip his sunglasses off in disbelief.

That was definitely Deku's ass.

"You have got to be shitting me," Katsuki exasperated loudly.

The figure in front of him stiffened at the sound of his voice and whirled around, clearly caught off guard. All too familiar green eyes widened by several fractions.

Yup. He was fucking right. It was Deku's ass.

Gradually, a look of absolutely fury fanned across both their faces.

"No." Deku shook his head in denial. "*Nuh-uh*. I refuse. This is not happening—"

"I agree, *it's not*. You need to fucking leave in the next five seconds," Katsuki hissed in a low whisper. The shorter male groaned and looked around at all the families and Katsuki knew he was having the same thoughts as he was: it was too crowded to make a scene and there was too much daylight.

"I'm not going anywhere. Why are you here!?" Deku accused unhappily and Katsuki scoffed.

"*Me*?! What the fuck are *you* doing here! If you're here to screw up another one of my marks I swear—"

"—I'm not the one always sticking his gun in other people's business!"

"Yes, the fuck you *do*—" Katsuki stopped himself and closed his eyes to lower his temper. *Count to ten. Count to fucking ten.* Katsuki ran his hands down his face in disbelief. "Please tell me you're here because you're some dumbass hopeless romantic and not because you're here on an assignment."

He watched Deku splutter and blush as if both were true.

Shit.

Katsuki glared daggers and shook his head. He wasn't putting up with this shit for eight days. *Especially* when he had direct orders to cut this man down.

"I'm not going to argue with you, Deku." Of all the places. Of all the goddamn places and all the goddamn assignments. "You're going to listen carefully and follow what I say and *leave*."

"I need to leave?" The green eyed man hissed in a whisper. His face twisted into an offended expression and he puffed out his cheeks. "I was here first!"

"Oh shut up, we're not five!"

"I swear if this ends up like that time we were in Taiwan I'm going to *actually* murder you."

Katsuki took a step forward and leaned down slowly several inches away. He could see the lightest freckles again this close. He curled his upper lip and looked the other man straight in the eyes. "As if you have the guts to kill me."

Deku fell short on his words and his eyes widened at the proximity.

In the silence, Katsuki's eyes darted down to the other's mouth automatically.

"—Well, what do we have here!" A loud booming voice cut through the air. Both men stiffened and turned their eyes to the counter where a tall man in a white suit with fair skin and brown hair waited for them. Katsuki swallowed thickly when he recognized the man within a second.

That was Peter Moore. That was the mark.

The unsuspecting man laughed and gestured to them to come up all the way to the marble counter. Both agents looked carefully at each other behind approaching together in a quiet understanding. The hotel owner smiled wide enough that his eyes crinkled at the ends and several lines telling of old age showed.

If Katsuki didn't know from his job that this man was an international criminal, he never would have guessed.

"I'm so sorry that no one has come to the counter yet but I have to just say you two are hilarious," Moore continued with an ignorant smile. His light brown eyes gazed between the two men happily. "You remind me of me and my wife at your age, ha! Always at each other's throats, we've also been to Taiwan. Lovely place."

Katsuki fumbled his sunglasses in his hands and that damn Deku choked on thin air. Both men awkwardly paused for several seconds because *what the fuck—*

"You are married, right?" Moore questioned with a minor frown. The affection in his eyes slowly turned to suspicious confusion and Katsuki realized their mistake. "You two fight as though you've been together for ten years, if not how do you two know each other?"

Katsuki's brain malfunctioned momentarily.

Shit. What should I stay? We're friends who casually say we're going to murder each other—fuck no. We're friends that are on a romantic getaway together and spent a week in Taiwan—fuck no not that either. Fuckfuckfuck—

"Y-Yes!" The Deku answered from beside him and quickly grabbed his arm. It took all of his years of professional training not to let surprise show on his face. "W-We are, um, this...is my husband."

Deku looked up at him with a plastic smile and Katsuki gave one right back in hopes to cover their slip up.

"*Yup*," he quickly agreed and the look of adoration was plastered right back across that slime ball trafficker's face. "Verbal berating is our own special way of affection. Excuse anything you may have heard."

"Yeah, you know how it is," Deku chuckled and playfully reached up and pinched his cheek too hard to be seen as loving. "Sometimes you just really...*really* want to wring your spouse's neck after so many years together."

Katsuki fought the intense urge to shove Deku to the ground.

"Ha! Yes, I understand that completely," Moore answered with a grin. "So how many years together?"

"Eight," they both answered automatically.

Katsuki's heart stumbled at the synchronization and he cut his eyes down to the freckled man hanging off his arm. Deku quickly averted his eyes and tucked a curl behind his ear.

"I knew it was near ten years," Moore said as he slapped his hands together, utterly proud of himself. "You two are adorable. My name is Henry Sekai. I'm the hotel owner and I was just making my rounds. I'm so sorry for the inexcusable wait. I don't know what happened to the person who was supposed to be checking people in at this counter."

"It's fine, don't worry about it, sir," the nameless Deku answered. Katsuki tried his best to ignore the feeling of heat rushing to his face when the smaller man clung to him tighter and leaned his head against his shoulder. "I'm sure you have several other things you need to attend to!"

"No no no, it's quite alright. I can check you two in," Moore insisted with a dismissive hand gesture. "As an apology for the wait and for the fact you two are such a hoot, I'll upgrade you to the honeymoon suite and itinerary. Even though you're clearly past honeymooning, it never hurts to try to reignite that spark!"

Both deadly agents gave a strained, dry laugh.

"What name is the reservation under?"

They opened their mouths but stopped short to look at the other. Katsuki took the lead quickly before they fucked up.

“—Bakugou is our last name,” he supplied. “It should be under Taro Bakugou.”

The hotel owner hummed in approval and typed in several things in the computer in front of them. The click-clack of the keyboard felt like an excruciating metronome the longer the warm, small body stayed pressed against him. How the fuck was he here with the man who had a knife to his jugular less than two days ago?

“Found it!” Moore exclaimed and Katsuki’s throat tightened. “Here you go Mr. & Mr. Bakugou!”

They were handed two pink hotel cards that had two shiny translucent golden hearts on the center of it. He leaned down confused at the sudden fruity smell of perfume because there was no way—but he was proven wrong. The key cards were fucking scented.

“I hope you enjoy your stay. Welcome to paradise!”

Paradise.

Katsuki never felt like he was in hell more than he did in that moment.

Chapter End Notes

I hope you enjoyed! Please let me know what you think below :)

Chapter 2: Duet

Chapter Summary

For eight years Katsuki burned to know Deku's real name. But he never anticipated that he would find out like this.

Chapter Notes

Hello!! Greetings! As a warning, this will start off slow and fluffy but don't trust me :/ Never trust me.

I started up a Spotify playlist for this fic. I already began curating a selective playlist for future scenes :) by the end it will probably include a lot of songs so here it is for your convenience:

https://open.spotify.com/playlist/1507sqwfBTN73ZT4SkSH61?si=H7_4QvnBRCyrQvAjdagpnA

Okay! I hope you enjoy! 💚🧡

Beta'd by the moon of my life, LunaToons on AO3 ❤️

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter Two: Duet

.

.

.

The very first time Katsuki saw the nameless man he deemed ‘Deku,’ it was in the city of Vienna, Austria eight years ago. Three years before his mother’s death when he was still an overconfident seventeen-year-old proud of the chip on his shoulder. He had been working for The Company officially for three years still gaining his bearings on everything.

It had been a quiet night when Deku waltzed in like a beautiful but deadly typhoon.

There was not not a single cloud in the sky and the air was crisp with the smell of after-rain teasing his senses. Katsuki’s assignment was to protect one of the country’s diplomats who

was coming and going after a large international gathering. He was accompanied by two other coworkers from The Company—one of which was his former work partner Rin Hiryu.

Hiryu was an agent Katsuki had only known for a short amount of time, but there was a peculiar air around him that Katsuki could never quite pin down. It was almost damn irritating how elusive the man's aura was despite having worked so many cases with him. Hiryu's long black hair was always slicked back into a neat braid that reached shoulder length and his skin was a perfect glossy tan.

A lot of impressively unique things stood out about Hiryu. The man was fluent in about twelve languages and skilled in multiple deadly fighting styles that Katsuki had never even heard of. It was as if he was born to do this type of job.

But what stood out the most was the tiny tattoo on the inside of his index finger on his right hand, the one used to pull the trigger: 102.

It was set in deep black ink and with a tiny font, an old American typewriter like style someone had taken his flesh and quickly stamped it while mass producing a product. But there was something so fucking *off* about it—and that was saying a lot by Katsuki's standards. He worked for The Company and had socialized with his fair share of shady ass individuals.

Katsuki watched mission after mission how Hiryu barely flinched when killing someone. Then one day he caught the elder man quietly staring at the tattoo on his finger like it was the DaVinci Code.

Curiosity had burned too strong after that and pushed Katsuki to finally ask Hiryu about it. But his question was only met with intense aloofness.

"Oh, it's just the anniversary date for my girlfriend and I." Hiryu's laugh was obnoxiously fake. "The tenth of February."

His smile was tight, passionless and immensely unfriendly. The honesty stopped right below the dark bags on his eyes, given away by the lack of facial muscles that failed to turn upwards. In their line of business, Katsuki took the hint: whatever that tattoo was, it wasn't any of his damn business.

But that night as they ignorantly prepped to move the Austrian diplomat, it would be the last time he ever saw Hiryu.

They exited out of the high security plaza and into a party that just smelled like the elite. If Katsuki could bottle up the scent of the restaurant that night, he would slap a label on it and call it 'filthy fucking rich' because there were no other words for it. The mix of the various gourmet foods with French perfumes and colognes he couldn't pronounce was almost overwhelming and made Katsuki scrunch his nose in aggravation.

He doesn't remember the name of the place, or whoever was the third guard member, but he remembers how calmly the waiter approached their table to serve drinks. Hiryu was too busy talking with the diplomats at the table to notice. The elder kept his head turned, training a

watchful eye at the entrance—but Katsuki's red eyes zeroed in immediately on the new figure.

When he fully focused, Katsuki's young mind was put in a trance.

The waiter looked around his age and dressed in a silk red blouse that was begging to be touched. To top it off, he wore fitted black dress pants that showed off the angles of his body and *damn*—he had the most perfect ass Katsuki had ever seen. It was full, curvy, and held the right balance between muscle and cushion. The waiter's head was full of soft looking dark green curls and his eyes—his fucking *eyes*—were large, doe like and the most striking shade of lightning green.

The waiter wore expensive looking ruby earrings that caught the light. The reflection of the luminescence from the diamond chandeliers above them gleamed through the gemstones and tiny specks of red and pink danced over his freckles. It made the other teenager in front of him alluring in a way that caused Katsuki to be mildly hypnotized.

The waiter's neat, non-threatening appearance held a gentle aura and there was not a single hint that he was carrying a loaded gun and knife strapped to his person.

Sparkling green eyes met Katsuki's blazing red ones briefly and they held the gaze for several seconds. Katsuki remembered how he couldn't resist smirking when a visible candy pink blush crept up from the waiter's neck to spill into his full cheeks.

The shy waiter offered Katsuki a gentle smile that pushed its way into his memory and would never leave for years to come. The tiny dimples that showed made Katsuki's young heart flutter.

It had felt so genuine.

Later that night, he was given the order to work on rooftop duty with Hiryu at the venue. The dinner and meeting for the diplomat had gone smooth and there wasn't a single threat in sight. The pair of sharp minded assassins waded over the ledge of the brick building, enveloped comfortably in silence sitting next to their loaded sniper guns.

Katsuki couldn't help but think about the cute waiter as Hiryu lit a cigarette.

He toyed with the idea that if he was a normal seventeen-year-old he would go back and flirt with the guy—possibly ask him out on a date. He wondered what it would be like to sit across a candle lit table and look at that sweet smile.

"Bakugou, can I tell you something personal?" Hiryu had spoken randomly. Katsuki watched as the grey smoke floated upwards and blended in with the night sky.

"Yeah, go for it, whatever."

"I'm thinking I'm going to disappear soon. I know my contract is still in play but—" Hiryu paused, licked his chapped lips and his eyes skirted off to the side. "Things in Japan are getting complicated."

Katsuki squinted his eyes at the hunched over man. “Complicated how?”

His comrade’s gaze swayed as if there was a fatal truth swimming in his eyes.

“Complicated as in I think I fucked up,” Hiryu mumbled. He took another drag of his choice of poison and exhaled the thick smoke shakily. “I was invisible for a long time, but I slipped up. Something from my past caught up to me and I need to make myself disappear before it can find me, if you catch my drift.”

Katsuki stared at him with a stone face as the smell of nicotine danced in his senses. He nodded slowly.

Someone’s trying to kill him he thought privately to himself.

“I understand,” Katsuki replied, staring down over the edge of the roof. He could see their mark safely leaving the scene and into the limousine with a higher security force. “It was nice working with you for what it’s worth.”

“You too, Bakugou,” Hiryu chuckled. “You know, you should get out of this lifestyle. I know everyone has been praising you since you joined, but you’re still so young and have some level of autonomy. You have time to turn things around and be normal.”

Normal.

Katsuki pursed his lips to the side as he thought about the cute green haired waiter.

Crimson red eyes followed the next drag of the half-used cigarette Hiryu took in silence. He decided against responding to that comment. Despite his unspoken fantasies of wanting to be normal, he needed this job. He had to help his mother out and there was no other way to settle all the money issues their family had without this gig. He wasn’t going to go back to being homeless and sleeping in sketchy ass warehouses.

The half-stressed smirk Hiryu graced him with was the final facial expression his colleague would ever give him.

That’s when they heard the clinking of metal.

In hindsight, Katsuki knew damn well he could never have connected the dots. However, that didn’t stop him from feeling the nerve shattering shock that struck his core the next split second. The only warning they were given was the slightest movement of a dark shadow in their peripheral blending in with the midnight atmosphere.

Both hitmen whipped their heads quickly at the sound, caught utterly off guard by the lack of footsteps only to see the waiter dressed in red with green eyes aiming a black gun directly at him.

Katsuki’s reflexes caused him to stand up and snap his hand to the gun at his waist but it all happened too quickly. The once honey warm green eyes were now mechanical, distant and cold as the mysterious teen pulled his finger on the trigger.

The first two shots landed directly in Katsuki's upper biceps and the next two landed in Hiryu's.

Both men screamed out in explosive agony and the next sensation assaulting Katsuki's senses was a hard elbow to his throat, forcing an unwilling choke out loud. He reached forward to try to grab the assailant through his pain, but within the next second, Katsuki was swiftly disarmed and his whole body was tripped up and shoved harshly to the cold ground. He could hear the numbing crack of his skull on the grey cement.

Katsuki hissed when his muscles spasmed all over, controlled by the hot pain of the lead deep inside his body. His vision tilted and twisted as if the green haired assailant had leveled the earth he walked on—which Katsuki would say that's exactly what fucking Deku did that night.

The frantic blond tried to scrabble back upright, but it was too late when the next two shots rang out, landing directly in Hiryu's knees, shattering his kneecaps. The older assassin fell to the ground like a flimsy house of cards that was stacked too arrogantly high and blood splattered all around.

The large body of Hiryu hit the cold cement of the roof and the green-eyed killer walked up over him to cast his looming shadow over their figures unforgivingly.

Betrayal and despair filled Hiryu's eyes.

"Mian haeyo, hyung," the mysterious killer whispered.

He coldly pulled the trigger despite one last desperate plea from Hiryu.

Katsuki squeezed his eyes shut before he could witness the gruesome hole put directly in his comrade's skull.

The piercing silence of death clawed its way up Katsuki's forearms, digging into his flesh. There was no more breathing. No more pleading. Just silence.

Katsuki's breathing became uneven, increasing in panic as he tried to think of a way out of the situation. But he also damned himself because how the *fuck* did they not sense this guy on the roof? Was he really that stealth?

The shy, naive look from earlier inside the restaurant made Katsuki feel like an absolute goddamn fool for ever romanticizing him.

Damn it all. Katsuki gritted his teeth together so painfully tight like the tension in a weak violin chord set to play its last note. He awaited the bullet that was surely going to penetrate his temple—but seconds passed by and nothing happened.

Katsuki's brows pinched together in confusion as he dared glance up.

There, he witnessed the green haired killer staring down at Hiryu's limp body with a distant gaze. The midnight air ran over Katsuki's face and he was able to feel the subtle sway of his hair in the wind as the dark curls of the killer moved as well.

Katsuki waited—and waited. Holding a delicate breath for death to happen.

But nothing arrived.

Forest eyes drank in the sight of the dead man at his feet as if he was studying it, memorizing all the ways the blood stains were soaking into Hiryu's black clothes. Time stood still while Katsuki watched the crimson decorated green eyed man slowly crouch down and gently close Hiryu's eyes with his leather gloved hands.

...What the fuck?

But before Katsuki could analyze any further, as quickly as the obscure moment came, it vanished. Those sharp emerald eyes snapped up to stare at him bleeding out on the concrete with both arms filled with bullet holes.

"I'm sorry you had to see that," the killer muttered in Japanese as he lifted his gun to aim at him. "It's nothing personal. You weren't my mark."

Katsuki flared his nostrils in panic.

"I'll kill you for this." He promised because all he could fucking see was red, red, *red*. He couldn't believe that this fucking green haired asswipe got the jump on him—

"Huh? You're saying *you* are going to kill *me* when *I'm* the one with the gun on *you*? You really are a mouthy one."

The green haired teen smiled in an unreadable way. Nothing like the smile he was given before—this was different. Distant and cold. His eyes didn't translate happiness—that same half effort smize Hiryu would give.

"Quit fucking toying with me! Why don't you just kill me already instead of fucking holding conversation?" Katsuki hissed as the pain in his arms worsened and he started to become lightheaded from the blood loss. The hot throb stemmed down to his fingertips, making his body tingle and rendering his arms useless.

He felt *weak*. Something he hadn't felt in three goddamn years. Now this guy was looking down on him like it was some game after killing Hiryu. It was *infuriating*.

Green eyes measured him up instead of replying.

They flickered up and down his body as the killer's finger toyed with the trigger as if he was going to pull it. But a single glance down at the dead body at his feet seemed to dull whatever blood lust that was in him. An emotionless veil was wrapped around the freckled face before he turned his head away from the sight of the bleeding body and pointed his gun downwards.

Katsuki watched both baffled and thankful as the other assassin stood up then turned his back to him.

His dark curls nearly blended in with the dark navy-blue sky above filled with ignorantly beautiful stars twinkling in the morbid moment. The red of his shirt absorbed Hiryu's blood

as the green-eyed killer wiped his gun clean before placing it in his hip's holster.

The nameless teen turned his head to the side and mumbled a promise that dug in underneath Katsuki's skin.

"Please stay out of my way," he whispered.

Then as quickly as he came—the mysterious green-eyed killer vanished back into the shadows. He left behind in his wake a pile of emotions rattled by the gravity of what occurred. Anger, sadness, confusion and above all *fury* boiled deep against Katsuki's chest as he was left rooftop with the dead body of his colleague. The thick blood pooling from Hiryu crept closer and closer to Katsuki while only one question rang loud in his head.

Who the hell was that?

And he would find himself asking this exact same question for the next eight years as the curiosity grew.

☽ ☽ ☽

The distant memory faded out of Katsuki's mind as he was escorted down the pastel pink colored hallway with his now *husband* whose name he still didn't know.

How all the events in his last twenty-five years of life led up to this was a goddamn mystery. Whenever Katsuki died, he had a few choice words for whatever deity was above them.

Untrusting red eyes carefully surveyed the smiling man stationed by his side as they were directed down a narrow hallway by a bubbly hostess. The thorn in his side next to him was clearly on high alert, but trying to play the part of the odd situation they found themselves in.

Deku was grinning wide and hanging off his arm as if he adored Katsuki and it was nearly appalling. However, it was convincing—and that's what they had to somehow be right now: a convincing ass married coupled.

But Katsuki didn't miss the way those cutthroat green eyes glanced up at him every few seconds while the ginger woman explained the various couples' activities that were available to them.

"Your new room will be up on the third floor!" She said with a large smile. "You're quite lucky. The boss rarely upgrades to the honeymoon suite for free. You must have made a great first impression on him!"

"Ah, he's just a sweet guy!" Deku laughed off awkwardly as he rubbed the back of his messy curls with his free hand. "We're super thankful, y'know? I feel so embarrassed that he heard us bickering like that."

"Don't feel bad. Bickering is a sign of real love!" The hostess flashed a pearly white smile.

Katsuki fought the urge to roll his eyes.

As they walked further down the hall, Katsuki studied the surroundings. It was as if he was transported to his version of what Dante's inferno looked like. The hotel doors were a classy mahogany color, but the numbers plates were pink fucking hearts with silver numbering. Couples were walking up and down the hallway holding hands, looking at their pamphlets and giggling.

He wearily glanced down to the five foot five killing machine next to him and grimaced.

This was a fucking *nightmare*.

When they arrived at the third floor they were led straight up to the biggest room at the very end of an over complicated maze. The door had a giant red heart stamped on it that held the number 342 in shiny golden number.

"Here you lovely people go!" Their designated hostess chimed as she handed them what seemed to be custom itineraries. "If you need anything please make sure to call downstairs. I'll be taking care of you during your extended stay. You two are part of group twenty-five so you'll meet the other couples in your group during dinner time tonight! Please be sure to be on time."

"Group twenty-five?" Katsuki grumbled. "What does that even mean? I didn't see anything about that in the advertisement." He scrutinized the pamphlet that was too small in his hands.

"Well, since we are so popular, we have everyone here sorted into smaller groups that have access to help avoid overcrowding the facilities such as the dining hall, spas and the pools." She gave a small giggle and Katsuki frowned. "You'll get paired up with a handful of other couples to spend during your week here!"

"That sounds great! Like a miniature community," that damned Deku said as if it was the best thing in the world.

"Yup! So please, enjoy your stay and be downstairs in the dining hall around 20:00 otherwise you'll miss your dinner."

With that she sauntered off. *Probably to lure a couple into the pink trap of death* Katsuki thought privately as he swiped the rose scented room key card through the lock.

As the door clicked open on the tiny flashing greenlight, the arm holding onto him grew tighter in anticipation. As they stepped in the room it was deathly quiet. The thin hairs on his arms slowly began to rise when the shorter male next to him finally withdrew his arm fully and they cut their eyes to each other.

The door clicked shut behind them and it was as if the same idea that ran to the forefront of their brain simultaneously. The pair of hitmen turned towards each other with snarls twisted on their faces and Katsuki nearly scoffed at how downright irritated Deku looked.

Katsuki didn't waste a single moment to launch at Deku with unbridled anger. He grabbed for the smaller man's floral shirt and slammed him against the wall, shaking the portraits of loving couples hanging up.

“What are you doing here?” Katsuki hissed slowly.

The smaller man made a move to grab his wrist and twist himself out of the pinned position, but Katsuki was having none of it. Not fucking today. He pushed his whole-body weight onto the other man, lifting Deku upwards on the wall until his feet dangled between the wall and his entire force of weight.

“Get off me!” Deku demanded and tried kicking him hard several times in the knees, but Katsuki clenched his jaw through the pain and firmly held his ground.

“Not until you tell me what the fuck you’re doing here!” He shook the other harshly and slammed him against the wall several times loud enough for whatever poor neighborhoods they had to hear. “I’m not messing around with you this time. I have a mark here I need to take out and I need to finish the job without *any* incidents this time! And you being here is a giant, walking *flaming* incident waiting to happen!”

“I said get off!” Deku nearly screamed.

Katsuki opened his mouth to retort but in a blink, Deku thrashed and launched forward, slamming together their foreheads with all his strength.

“—*Fuck*!” Katsuki staggered and squeezed his eyes shut at the impact.

His head pounded loudly as he tried to keep his grip that immediately went slack as Deku twisted out of his hold and unkindly shoved him backwards in the small table in the center of the room.

Katsuki staggered briefly before clutching his forehead that was throbbing in pain. Their twin labored breathing could be heard throughout the room as the tensions grew higher. Katsuki could feel his gut twisting with anger but most of all anxiety. He couldn’t blow this assignment up like the last one.

Deku opened his mouth to say something but a small knock from the door interrupted him.

Both men turned their head towards the wooden in high alerts as they stared at it baffled. Neither made a move to answer it.

“Is everything going alright in there?” The familiar voice of Peter Moore echoed through. Katsuki’s eyes went wide in sync with the other man in the room as they both began to feel panic. “There was a call from your neighbors to the front desk about really loud concerning noises.”

Katsuki cursed under his breath.

“Y-Yes, we’re fine!” Deku quickly answered throughout the door. The shorter man’s posture straightened out as he quickly opened the door up wide. “I’m so sorry about that! We didn’t mean to make so much noise.”

Deku beamed that fake smile that stopped below his eyes.

Peter Moore's eyes scanned up and down their bodies in an uncomfortable manner. *What the hell is he looking at?* At first Katsuki made a face of distaste as the disgusting man's eyes lingered a little too long on his figure but when a look of amusement graced the hotel owner's face, Katsuki finally took a good glance between him and Deku.

Their clothes were thoroughly ruffled. Green curls and blond spikes were tousled in every direction and Deku's breathing was still evening out in hard breaths as his stupid loose-fitting shirt was slouched off his shoulder.

"*Oh*. I see." The man chuckled in a suggestive manner and flexed one eyebrow. Katsuki hated the way Deku blushed. "Well, I see this was a misunderstanding. You were being loud for other reasons. But, just in case, remember, no fighting in paradise! Only happy times here. I have a very low tolerance for disrupting the peaceful environment here."

"Got it," Katsuki said curtly with a sarcastic smile. "We'll be sure to keep it down from now on. No need to check in on us."

There was an awkward pause between the three of them.

Katsuki narrowed his sharp eyes ever so slightly when Peter shifted on his feet to survey the two of them carefully. If Katsuki had learned anything from being on this job for so long it was how to spot when someone was discreetly assessing him.

Peter Moore was sizing them up, and his light brown eyes stopped on both of their ring fingers—their very *empty* ring fingers.

Shit.

The trafficking leader wiped off the suspicious look before giving a near convincing gleeful expression. "I'll be seeing you guys in a couple minutes for dinner. I've decided to give a special toast to your group."

"That's wonderful to hear! I would love to ask you more questions about the spa here," Deku said with a lopsided smile as he readjusted his shirt. "We'll be down shortly!"

Peter Moore bowed slightly at the waist before smiling tightly. "Yes. See you soon."

The hotel owner walked away in his all-white suit as Deku quietly closed the door again. The shorter man let out a heavy sigh before turning around with his arms crossed.

"He's suspicious of us," Deku pointed out unhappily.

"Yeah, no shit, Sherlock," Katsuki barked back. The nervous blond carded his hand through his hair before shaking his head. "We need to be more discreet unless we both want to blow whatever assignments we have."

The green haired man kicked his foot gently in defeat.

"...That man is my mark. I have orders to take him out quietly."

Katsuki paused and looked at Deku curiously.

“Seriously?” Katsuki said surprisingly.

He searched at the shorter man’s freckled face for any hint of deception but found nothing. Deku was telling the truth.

“Yeah,” the freckled hitman mumbled. “He, um, crossed a higher up and my handler is demanding that he be put down.”

Upon hearing those fateful words, the situation started clicking together in Katsuki's mind like grinding gears. He almost gave an exasperated sigh of relief because damn—for the first time in *eight* years it finally seemed like he and this green-eyed menace were on the same side.

That means they could team up rather than fight and *boom*—retirement was as good as golden. It should be easy as cake, right? Especially because, as much as he hated to admit it, Deku was a damn good assailant.

“Well, I guess that works out for us both in whatever miracle,” Katsuki mumbled, which earned him a strange look from the other man.

“And why do you say that?”

Katsuki absolutely detested the way Deku scrunched his button nose in suspicion. It was almost endearing.

“My agency has been hired by two separate governments to take him out as well,” Katsuki explained carefully. “He’s wanted in several countries dead or alive and it seems like everyone is leaning towards dead.”

An unwanted feeling prickled at his skin as Deku’s eyes searched him with a newfound intensity. It was the first time in a long time those green eyes laid sights on him in a manner outside of violence. Katsuki could see the various gears of thought in the curly man’s head clogging together slowly, putting together their odd situation.

However, when those damn doe eyes stared at him too long, trying to see if there was a thread of lie woven into his words, Katsuki’s gut twisted. It reminded him of the emotions he felt when he first met Deku and how naive he had been.

When the sensation became too intense, Katsuki huffed loudly in annoyance to shoo away the feeling.

“Look, I have the assignment folder in detail if you want to see it if you don’t believe me,” he offered when the edge in Deku’s posture didn’t leave. “If we’re going to play husbands while attempting to land a bullet in that man’s skull we’re clearly going to have to work together.”

Those seemed to be the magic words because Deku’s shoulders visibly untensed for the first time since the lobby downstairs.

“Okay, show me the folder.”

“Only if you show me yours too.”

Katsuki didn’t miss the odd way Deku’s eyes flickered to the side for a millisecond.

“Alright, fine.”

Both men turned on their heels, eyes cutting at one another. They bent down towards their respective bags stationed by each other and carefully opened up their luggage. Katsuki carefully unzipped his worn down red bag to dig carefully underneath his clothes. He could hear Deku rummaging beside him as well until his hand found the red folder buried securely at the bottom.

As he lifted it, it felt distinctly heavier than he remembered. He knew why as he heard the walking nightmare beside him exhale. This was absolutely insane. He stopped for a moment to really examine himself, taking in the feeling of the thick paper against his finger pads.

Aizawa would shoot him in the foot if he found out about this...but then again, Aizawa would also shoot him in the foot if this mission went fucking wrong again.

“Here you go,” the quiet voice beside him spoke up.

Red eyes cut to the side to see a small hand thrusted forward in his face, clutching a nearly identical red folder. Katsuki was honestly glad to see some hesitation in the other hitman because it meant he had a lot riding on this too, which meant less fuck ups for both of them.

They exchanged red folders without a word and Katsuki carefully opened the other folder, scanning it carefully. In the center there was an odd “V” sigil stamped in obsidian colored ink. Katsuki tilted his head curiously, examining the symbol, trying to ingrain it into his memory. The V was encircled by two twin snakes that had their teeth bared meeting at the top and underneath it was a number: 217.

The same one that was tattooed on Deku in the picture he was shown by Aizawa.

Red eyes flickered over to the green haired man next to him, eyeing the clothed clavicle area.

He glanced back over and opened it to reveal a clear mugshot of Peter Moore with red ink scribbled underneath: *Assassinate*. When he read through the rest, all the information and it all checked out. The blond man thumbed the pages as he absorbed the written words, nodding as he read on.

Deku’s mark was clearly Peter Moore. All his background criminality was listed. There were clear instructions to discreetly dispose of him, stage it to look like either a suicide or frame someone else for the murder. Katsuki’s eyebrows shot up in surprise when there was a given list of people to possibly frame if need be.

He flipped through the pages until he came across one sentence that made him stop short.

Crimson eyes carefully looked up at his supposed husband beside him.

“It says in here you’re supposed to eliminate any loose ends that know about your assignment,” He pointed out. “How do I know you’re not going to turn on me when this is all over?”

Deku nonchalantly shrugged, not even bothering to look up. Curious green eyes stayed focused on reading his own red folder, flipping through the pages as if he was reading a magazine of sorts.

“All my assignments say that,” the freckled man mumbled as if it was the tiniest detail. “Don’t worry about it. If I was going to kill you, I would have by now.”

Katsuki ‘tch’d and sarcastically rolled his eyes. “How thoughtful of you.”

“Of course, *hubby*.”

Katsuki's upper lip curled up at the mocking tone.

Deku looked up at him with a fake sweet smile and closed the folder. “Well, it looks like everything checks out! I guess this means we’re at a truce while here.”

“A truce?” Katsuki mocked. “We were never at war in the first place. You’re just always in my way, like a roach that won’t fucking die.”

Truthfully, this wouldn't be their first truce. Katsuki knew him and Deku had few and far truces between them. Over the years they sometimes found themselves at roadblocks or too tired to keep fighting. So in silent agreement they would call it and go on with their lives.

“I could argue it’s the opposite. Now, c’mon and loosen up, things could be a lot worse. We’re in paradise, on an easy mission. This could be fun with the two of us! I know you’re more than capable of doing your job and you know I’m better than you at mine.”

Katsuki rolled his eyes as he sat down Deku's red folder on the floor. “Don’t sound so damn excited about it. We’re still here to kill someone.”

“Jeez, you really are a grumpy one. Cheer up,” Deku muttered under his breath. “This is basically a vacation now. All we have to do is our jobs and maybe we can even have some time to enjoy ourselves since two of us should make the mission go quicker. I’ve never had any spare time before or after on an assignment.”

“You’ve never had any extra time in your given windows?”

“I don’t have windows, I have timelines.” Katsuki didn’t miss the slight way Deku’s words hardened with seriousness. “I am told precisely what to do and when. Then ordered back to headquarters.”

“And where is headquarters?” He pushed his luck, because why the hell not. He was given another lopsided smile in return and a curious head tilt.

“Wouldn’t you like to know.” Deku playfully winked at him. “Alright, let’s go Taro. We can’t miss dinner and I’m starving.”

“And what’s my husband’s name by chance?” Katsuki asked bitterly as he zipped back up his suitcase.

The question hung in the air as they both paused in silence. Deep down, Katsuki burned to know—he had been for a long while ever since that fateful night on the rooftop. Bright green eyes looked into his and Katsuki waited, ignoring the stupid way his heart rate increased in anticipation.

“My name is Hiroji.”

Hiroji.

For the first time he was given a title to match the nameless hitman, a name other than Deku —but something felt off.

He could see Deku—or Hiroji—pause to assess if he would believe the given name. But it didn’t sit right, his brain struggled to make it fit like fingers trying to jam a square into a circle shaped hole. Red eyes studied the silk curls, the full cheeks and cute—er—*non-cute* freckles.

“Alright then Hiroji,” he said slowly. The syllables curled wrong against his tongue. “Let’s go to dinner and start this.”

Tension loosened between them and a newfound understanding blossomed.

The freckled man smiled wide and bright, something he had never seen. Green eyes turned upwards into crescent moons and the expression of genuine joy danced across Deku’s face.

Small dimples peeked through the vast array of freckles littered on the other’s honey kissed skin. He hadn't seen those dimples in eight years. And, he begrudgingly was happy to. Katsuki didn’t realize that he had been waiting to see them again until now.

At that moment, Katsuki finally understood why Hiroji didn’t seem right.

It couldn’t be his name because it didn’t match his smile.

☽ ☽ ☽

When they arrived at the dining hall, Katsuki was begrudgingly impressed.

Unlike the rest of the tacky hotel, it lacked the ugly trademark pink color and was a lot less of an eye sore to the anti-romantic man. Instead, the large dining hall was painted in an elegant beige color with gold trimming all around. The ceiling was curved with a sky-blue painting on top of angels and clouds. Couples and singles bustled in and out of the hall with waiters in classic black and white attire shuffling food to various numbered tables.

“Whoa,” Deku—er, *Hiroji* whispered beside him. Large emerald eyes were sparkling like he had never seen anything like the crystal chandelier lights above them. “This is so gorgeous.”

“It is,” Katsuki reluctantly agreed as he eyed the painted angels above them.

As he scanned over the masterpiece, there was one part of the painting that drew him in as he studied it more. Katsuki tilted his head to the side as he noticed two figures were painted off in the corner, one limp in the other's arms while being given a small green potion.

Katsuki furrowed his brows when he noted that the figure laying limp seemed nearly lifeless. The look of death on the man's face unnerved him for how out of place it was in this type of setting.

"*Bakugous*!" The loud voice of Peter Moore boomed through the crowd. "Over here! I saved you two seats!"

Both hitmen tore their eyes away from the beautiful painting above them to the sound of the voice from their target. Their heads searched the crowd until landing on a small round table filled with three other couples and the man of the hour.

"Get ready to smile, grumpy," Hiroji said quietly as they both started walking over to the table. Katsuki huffed and made sure not to smile just to spite the other man. Fuck him.

"Everyone, these are the Bakugous. They are the last couple in your group," Peter introduced as he gestured to everyone sitting around.

"Hi you guys! So nice to meet you!" A pink haired woman greeted with a smile as bright as her hair.

A chorus of awkward hellos and introductions quickly took place as he and Hiroji took their seats next to each other at the mahogany table. As everyone went around, Katsuki took the time to quietly examine the three other couples at the table as they all introduced themselves. All of them had twinkling wedding rings on their hands and were smiling happily.

The first couple to speak up and say their names were Ashido-Kirishima Eijiro and Mina as they sat down. The couple had such annoyingly loud colored hair that there was no doubt in Katsuki's mind that hair dying night was a weekly ritual in their home.

The next couple to introduce themselves were Yaoyorozu Momo and Jirou Kyouka. Katsuki was almost surprised to learn the two were engaged with how extremely contrasting their styles were. Momo was dressed as if she owned several mansions and Jirou was dressed like a punk rock star. But there was a deep aura of 'I would take a bullet for this woman' radiating from both women as their fingers intertwined.

Then lastly to introduce themselves were a couple that Katsuki was damn near impressed by the size difference. The big bulky man by the name of Todoroki Inasa held out his hand for a handshake and he easily dwarfed Hiroji's hand in his own. He was loud, upbeat and very determined to get to know everyone.

However, it came across as if Inasa's husband had an entirely different demeanor to him. The shorter male who introduced himself as Todoroki Shouto had two toned hair split down the middle in red and white. He was slender and had an air of elegance to him.

"It's so nice to meet you two!" Inasa boomed as he reached over to grab Katsuki's hand.

“Nice to meet you all as well,” Katsuki said with a clenched smile and he took a far too aggressively excited handshake. *Damn this man is strong.* “How’s everyone enjoying their trips so far?”

“Wonderfully!” Mina giggled while placing her hand over her husband’s. “We all checked in today so I’m super excited to get to the good stuff tomorrow. There’re so many activities here it’s wonderful.”

“Yeah same,” Kyouka said as she adjusted the sunglasses on top of purple hair. Katsuki watched her eyes flicker down to the hands. “Ah, it’s nice to have someone else in the group who isn’t married yet. I was beginning to think we got placed in the wrong section.”

Both Katsuki and Hiroji froze awkwardly in their chairs.

Katsuki watched the way Hiroji stumbled and quickly shook his head. “Oh, no. We’re—”

“They’re actually husbands,” Peter Moore corrected with a tight smize. His piercing brown eyes cut over to the pair of them and Katsuki’s hairs stood up on his arm at how there was an underlying suspicion carried in the words. “I ran into them in the lobby earlier today. They’re downright hilarious, you’ll love them.”

Katsuki gave a painfully awkward nod and readjusted himself.

“Oh, sorry for assuming!” Kyouka quickly backtracked and threw her hands up. “I didn’t see any rings on your fingers, so I thought—”

“—We take them off while traveling to places, in case we accidently lose them,” Hiroji quickly cut in with a subtle nervous chuckle. “Taro nearly chewed my head off once because I forgot mine in the airport security area in Taiwan once.”

All eyes automatically turned towards him as if anticipating him to tack on to the story. Because *apparently* that was a thing married couples did.

“They were expensive,” Katsuki mumbled dryly.

“Oh, so *that’s* what happened in Taiwan,” Peter chuckled. “I was going to ask because I was admittedly curious.” The hotel owner leaned back in his chair and slicked his palm through his brown hair, visibly relaxing.

Like clockwork, everyone started nodding in agreeance, eating up the lie like it was actually believable.

Gullible. The whole goddamn lot. The ill-tempered hitman bit back the strong urge to groan because he didn’t know how he was going to deal with *this* bullshit. He knew he would have to socialize but this just became far more complicated and friendly than he cared for.

“That’s such a smart idea!” Inasa boomed and turned to Shouto next to him who was the only person who didn’t seem to buy the story all the way. “Shouto, we should start doing that. You nearly left your wedding band at the last hotel we were at.”

“Yeah,” Shouto spoke slowly, but his mix-matched eyes didn’t leave Katsuki’s figure. “We can start doing that.”

Katsuki noted the way the man’s heterochromatic eyes looked between him and Hiroji as if trying to find another reason laying in the empty space between them.

Thankfully the topic at the table shifted to some boring story about Momo always having to find things for Kyouka. Truthfully, Katsuki didn’t bother even fully listening to it. He heard bits and pieces but he toned the rest out, not caring to listen to some domestic bullshit he probably would never experience. It was so goddamn mundane—utterly *normal* to the point Katsuki bet that if he could taste the conversation it would rival stale bread.

When he glanced beside him at Hiroji, the other hitman had an entirely different reaction. The freckled man was leaned forward across the table, eyes alert and hanging on her words like they were the most fascinating thing in the world.

What a weirdo.

☽ ☽ ☽

As the night went on and various platters were brought to the table, Katsuki played the stoic, quiet husband to Hiroji’s bubbly personality. The green-eyed man next to him looked as if he was in his element, easily getting along with all the others at the table who matched his energy. He radiated professional social butterfly energy and it was not what Katsuki was anticipating out of him.

Out of all the things he expected ‘Hiroji’ to be, social butterfly wasn’t it.

The grumpy blond admittedly thought of all the various personality traits annoying ass Deku/Hiroji would have over the eight years. It wasn’t because he liked the guy or anything—fuck no. He stopped finding him cute the second he took Hiryu out in cold blood—or at least he tried.

Katsuki had to convince himself that sweet smile was stupid, and the rest of the man was probably dumb as well.

Hiroji was probably a smart ass that no one liked. All his coworkers probably found him to be clumsy and the most annoying brat at the agency. The stupid freckled short stack was most likely one of those people with terrible timing constantly in every way in life. Like barging in the room at the wrong moment or calling at the least convenient times. Hell, maybe he even snored too fucking loudly.

However, as he listened to his supposed husband meld with everyone around him, Katsuki realized Hiroji was likeable. *Extremely* likeable as Mina declared they should become his best friend by the time dessert arrived. Which happened to be pink frosted chocolate cake—*of course.*

But even as the night progressed, his mind couldn’t let go of the notion that Hiroji wasn’t the green-eyed man’s true name.

When everyone had finished eating, Katsuki quietly surveyed Peter who was having a goddamn blast at the table, playing like he was completely engrossed by the conversation.

“So how did you two meet?” Mina asked full of spirit. Her golden eyes twinkled while ignoring fawning over the pair of hitmen in front of him. “You two are so cute together I just know it had to be something romantic.”

Katsuki resisted rolling his eyes. What the hell was the fixation these people had on romance?

“We met at a restaurant in Vienna,” Hiroji supplied easily and Katsuki nearly gave a dry laugh. The irony was thicker than Peter Moore’s criminal history.

“Oh, Vienna is the perfect setting!” Mina swooned and tilted her head. “Was it one of those super dramatic meetings? Like you tripped but he caught you just in the nick of time?”

“Ha, no,” Hiroji giggled and that stupid goddamn blush flushed across his cheeks again. “I was actually working as a waiter at the time across seas. It was my first day on the job and I happened to be assigned his table.”

Katsuki froze as he listened to the story align to their real first meeting. He didn’t know what he was expecting Hiroji to say—maybe make up a fake story? Say something generically cheesy?

“I was unbelievably nervous about messing up,” Hiroji continued, glancing down at his fingers that he was twiddling with in an anxious manner. “He was super kind whenever I seemed to trip up on pronouncing the German words on the menu. When he smiled at me, I was a goner.”

A soft collective symphony of awes and ‘that’s so sweet’ filled the air and Katsuki stared Hiroji dead in his face.

What the hell was this guy's angle romanticizing that?

Green eyes slowly looked at him and for some reason it didn’t feel like much of a lie when Hiroji gave that same sweet smile—damn near identical to the one that had originally captured him eight years ago.

Katsuki’s chest tightened in an odd manner.

“What made you two talk to each other?” Shouto asked Hiroji with a smile. “Did you slip him your number on a piece of napkin?”

Hiroji gave a strained laugh that rudely reminded Katsuki that this was all fake.

Of *course,* Hiroji was over exaggerating. Who was he kidding? That damn man never felt that way about him in the first place. The tightening in his chest quickly boiled down to a familiar bitter sensation. A sneer enveloped the blond’s face as he stabbed his fork into the stupid slice of pink cake in front of him.

“Actually, Taro had—”

“—He shot me.” Katsuki tacked on resentfully to throw off the other man. “Twice.”

The entire table’s conversations came to a crashing halt and Hiroji balked.

“I’m sorry, wh-what?” Momo nervously chuckled, perfectly arched eyebrows raising sky high.

Shouto was staring wide at them in disbelief and the two Ashido-Kirishimas were just nodding like it was actually a rad way of meeting someone.

“He’s joking!” Hiroji quickly deflected, waving his hands frantically. “Taro is a really big jokester; I would never shoot anyone. Especially not him. Right, *sweetie*?” There was a bite to the endearing name that sounded more like a threat. Deku looked at him like he was going to strangle him.

“Of course, I’m joking.” Katsuki gave a condescending smile back as he took an aggressive bite of the pink cake. “You should see the stupid look on all your faces. What I meant to say was it *felt* like he shot me.”

“And what do you mean by that?” Peter Moore asked with a concerned look.

“He came into my life quickly,” Katsuki muttered reluctantly, trying to fit together words that made sense. “Quick and fast like an annoying little bullet you can’t see coming.”

Every pair of eyes were on him as all the couples were waiting for more than that to come out of his mouth. He glanced to the side at Hiroji and awaiting him was an underlying look of disappointment.

Green eyes flickered down and the small smile that had been there all night was washed away.

Katsuki bit the inside of his cheek at the sudden look of disillusionment. His stomach coiled again for an entirely different reason.

“I meant…when he first came up to me, Hiroji’s presence shocked me, y’know?” Katsuki muttered suddenly. He looked away from Hiroji when the green-eyed man glanced back at him curiously. “I’m no good at that mushy crap but, uh. He was dressed in all red. Not that cheap cherry red color either. No, he was dressed in a really elegant shade of red—like expensive wine—a deep crimson.”

He paused to fully recall the initial breathtaking imagery of the man next to him whose life seemed to be always intertwined with his own.

The words spilled out on their own.

“The color highlighted his eyes,” Katsuki heard himself describing. It was a bizarre experience as he thought about the fateful night from so long ago and soon it flowed out like

a river. Believable. Almost normal. “When he looked at me, I felt like his gaze had pierced through me—like a bullet. I had no way of anticipating him.”

Katsuki turned to hold Hiroji’s eye contact.

“It was hard not to want to know someone’s name after that,” he confessed.

The silence that followed that sentence was the loudest thing Katsuki ever experienced. Emerald eyes flickered across his face, sinking deep into him in a way that they hadn’t before. They danced to his own ruby colored eyes. Then to his nose and finally landing on his lips.

And they stayed there for one second too long.

“So, you two meeting *was* incredibly romantic,” Mina sighed with a large daydreamy expression. “I knew it had to be something absolutely stunning! Ahh, I wish me and Ei had met with something like that. I had gotten lucky and swiped right on him on Tinder while drunk.”

“Yeah,” Hiroji whispered distractedly, not truly paying attention.

Then as quickly as it came, the moment shattered into thin air. Green eyes urgently looked away from him as if it was wrong and they shouldn’t be indulging in whatever small spell had fallen over them.

“Well, who wants another round of dessert?” Peter said with a hearty laugh. “It’s on me!”

Everyone agreed but Katsuki noted how much quieter Hiroji had become.

☽ ☽ ☽

Dinner concluded with Peter Moore flexing his annoying amount of blood wealth to the point Katsuki was contemplating ending the mission by launching his fork down his throat.

It was almost unnerving how effectively charming the kingpin was. But luckily for both of them, they passed whatever test the man had put them through to go out of his way to join them at dinner.

The night concluded with them all shaking hands and saying goodbye to Peter Moore who insisted that he had to be on his way to make sure everything was in order for another busy day at the hotel.

Everyone dispersed to their rooms but him and Hiroji barely spoke a word back up to the honeymoon suite.

Something was going back and forth in the green haired man’s mind and Katsuki wished that he could at the very minimum see what it was. It was infuriating and nerve wrecking to have to trust the one man he was technically told by Aizawa to kill on sight.

“We need to get rings,” Hiroji muttered as he opened the door to the room.

“Yeah.” Katsuki grumbled and nodded while swiping through google on his phone. “I looked up where to buy jewelry and there's a small shop that’s a couple minute walk away that sells rings, but it’s closed right now. I’m sure we can find something cheap there in the morning.”

Hiroji wordlessly nodded as he walked towards his suitcase and quickly grabbed his belongings out of it.

When finally inside, Katsuki actually took the time to stare around the honeymoon suite. He hadn’t before, too pumped with adrenaline and pinning down the green-eyed hitman when they first entered.

It was nice, even by Katsuki’s standards.

The room had several photos of happy couples hung on the pastel pink wall to fill the air of romance, and a couple oil paintings on the wall to give it a true homely feel. There was a classic grey couch next to the large heart shaped king-sized bed. The silk red covers covered the mattress, the liquid cloth and the dresses spotted vases filled with red roses.

This room would’ve made some couples extremely happy.

He couldn’t help but feel like they were robbing someone out of a good time as both of them stared at the room for the first time, the romantic ambiance gone fully to waste.

Neither man said anything about the one bed situation and Katsuki decided he sure as hell wasn’t about to have that conversation as he opted for the couch without being prompted.

He earned a small look of disapproval from Hiroji, but the freckled man seemed to stop himself from saying whatever objections he had. Instead, the tired curly haired man turned on his heels and went directly to the bathroom to shower.

After an hour of the shower running, Katsuki stripped down to his boxers, switched into a plain tee and laid out on the decently sized grey couch. He shuffled himself into the plush cushions with a spare blanket until he got comfortable and sleep started weighing heavy on his eyes.

The bathroom door across the way creaked open, and the greenette came back out with his hair damp and dressed in oversized light blue PJs that completely masked all lethality attached to him. The far too large cotton shirt was covered in cutesy tiny pink hearts with matching bottoms that swallowed his feet whole.

Red eyes blinked once and then blinked again at the sight in front of him.

Katsuki hated to admit it but Hiroji looked—adorable.

“Um, I think we should start getting to know each other. You know, for the mission,” the freckled man said while pulling an item out of his red suitcase. “In case we get asked more questions we should be prepared.”

“Okay,” Katsuki agreed easily. “Yeah, for the mission.”

He nodded and looked down at what the other man was holding and was surprised to see a worn-down book in his hand. The spine was creased as if it had been abused and read over and over.

“So where are you from, Taro?” Hiroji asked while getting comfortable in the heart shaped king-sized bed by himself with the tiny book.

Katsuki mused to himself while studying the other man. The green-eyed man looked as if the red silk sheets were going to swallow him whole—hell, it almost looked *wrong* to have such a small person in the bed clearly meant for two by themselves.

“I was born and raised in Tokyo.”

Hiroji tilted his head to the side, bright eyes surveying him. “What part?”

“San’ya, or what’s left of it anyways,” he confessed. The enunciate of his birthplace felt foreign to his ears after such a long time avoiding saying it.

He was given dead silence in return and immediately regretted his decision to speak about his hometown. Why had he told the truth?

Usually, he would lie and say somewhere else like a richer ward to avoid awkwardness. Anything but his home neighborhood that was well known for his economic issues and missing persons in contrast to the rest of Tokyo.

Why hadn’t he lied?

Katsuki stared up at the ceiling in stillness. There was no response from Hiroji, but that was typical. Utter silence and unneeded sympathy were usually the reactions he received from other people from Japan when they heard the name of the forgotten city.

The quiet became too heavy on his ears after a while so he shot the question back.

“How about yourself, Deku? Where are you from?”

“I’m actually from Tokyo as well.”

Katsuki nodded, unsurprised. Tokyo was large and dense. “Where at?”

“Taito—but not the parts that absorbed San’ya,” the gentle voice whispered. Katsuki briefly stopped to consider how much of a coincidence that was that they grew up that closely to each other. “How old are you?”

“Twenty-five.” Katsuki replied. “You?”

“Same age.”

The blond cut his eyes to the freckled man next to him. His fake husband was staring up towards the ceiling fan as if absorbing the information carefully.

“What’s your favorite color, Taro?”

“Seriously?” Katsuki snorted at the lame question. “I don’t think anyone is going to ask you what goddamn color I like—”

“—I like red,” Hiroji quickly interjected. Katsuki rolled his eyes but the other man clutched the tiny book in his hands and turned to him as if he was saying something important. “My favorite color is red, and my favorite food is katsudon. I think rain is a pretty sound and my favorite type of music is violin music.”

Katsuki opened his mouth—but didn’t know what to really say.

Violin music?

A small, distant memory blurred in the back of his mind.

“Er. I think we should know small things about each other as well as big things,” Hiroji murmured shyly. “It helps make the story we’re trying to sell more believable while we’re here.”

Katsuki stared at the freckles on the other man, trying his best to chase the fickle foggy memory that had come and gone like sand in his fingertips. But it had slipped away from him and caused his gut to feel bizarre.

“I like...green,” he muttered.

“Green is a nice color. How about your favorite sport?”

“Baseball. What’s yours?”

“I enjoy keep up with figure skating. Never did it though.”

They kept going back and forth like this—asking questions until he found himself answering with his eyes closed and the blanket nearly covering his face. He found out Hiroji’s favorite movie was some sort of romantic superhero movie he never heard of, and that unlike Katsuki, he could only handle so much spicy food a week. Didn’t have the correct digestive system for it.

By the time he felt like he knew every nuance and useless fact about the other hitman, Katsuki had enough. He was drifting in and out of consciousness while Hiroji was thumbing through that tiny novel’s oldish tinted yellow pages.

“What’s your favorite type of dessert, Taro?”

“Sleep. A big fucking helping of it.”

“Hey, I’m serious!”

“Me too. That’s enough questions for one night, nerd. I’m fucking tired,” Katsuki muttered as he fully turned on his side facing the large heart shaped bed. “We got stupid ass couples’

aerobics in the morning and we need to start brainstorming about how we're going to find a way to get the mark isolated."

"Ah, okay, well goodnight," Hiroji said but didn't change his upright position. Instead the man cut off the lights in the room only to leave the tiny desk lap by him on—for reading of all things.

It was oddly normal and domestic.

Katsuki closed his eyes and tried to drift off as he struggled to attempt to recall that distant memory with no luck. His senses kept telling him to go to sleep but his brain refused. After everything the past eight years, his nerve endings were on high alert, waiting for the other body in the room to show signs of sleeping so that he could go to sleep—but it never happened.

Instead, the smaller man stayed up reading until nearly 02:44 flipping through those pages gradually.

"Are you still awake?" Hiroji's voice whispered.

Katsuki slowly opened his eyes and stared up at the ceiling. "Yeah."

There was a beat of silence and shifting in the bed. Katsuki eventually turned his head fully and looked to see lightning green eyes staring at him like he was a book to be read instead. Inquisitiveness danced across the freckled face as Hiroji's small pink tongue darted out to nervously lick his lips as if scared to say his next words.

"...Is your name really Taro?"

Katsuki huffed loudly and immediately tore his eyes away from the other man. How goddamn stupid did Deku think he was?

"Go to bed. I'm not telling you my real name."

"I promise I won't use it against you. I'm only curious after all this time—"

"—I fucking said *no*." Katsuki snapped loudly before he could catch himself. "Why the hell would I give you my real name when you've tried to kill me on several occasions and have fucking shot me countless times?"

There was a pause and Katsuki could hear Hiroji shift on the bed.

"I've never tried to kill you," the deceiving gentle voice weakly defended.

If Katsuki didn't know better he would've mistaken the voice for someone else, not a deadly killer.

"Whatever. Just drop it," Katsuki hissed and turned all the way over. "I don't give out my real name to people in our line of work. *Especially* not people like you."

“Right.” Hiroji’s voice was tight, strung high with tension as if he was unhappy with the reality of the situation. “That’s understandable. Sorry for asking.”

“Goodnight,” Katsuki grumbled and threw the covers over his head. “And put the fucking book away. Reading in the dark is bad for your eyes and you need to stay sharp.”

“I will soon, I just got to the good part.”

Soon never came, and Katsuki's body didn’t want to relax until it did.

He peaked over his shoulder to see the other man just sitting there neatly—still reading in the near dark room. The tiny yellowish light source from the bedside lamp only illuminated enough space to reach the printed words on the page. There was no doubt in Katsuki’s mind that the nerd was straining his eyes as he squinted slightly and pulled the book closer to his freckled face.

Gradually a tiny smile cracked on his face and Deku bit his lip to suppress a laugh. That tiny spark of joy of whatever Deku was reading made him seem—human.

Normal.

Like the roles they were supposed to be playing were true: two regular people together on a getaway.

He knew he shouldn’t. He knew he *really* shouldn’t—but once again the words came tumbling out before he could get a hold on them. Almost as if they were drawn out by the mere gravity of the man in front of him.

“My real name is Katsuki.”

His heart hammered unkindly against his chest.

Green eyes perked up to stare directly at him. Surprise. Astonishment—a hint of revelation was also mixed in there. All those stupid emotions swirled inside all too intensely for the blond who preferred to ignore such things.

“Katsuki?” Hiroji said. His tongue curved around all the syllables and those never-ending forest colored eyes never left his. The grip on the book grew tighter. “That’s a nice name. I-It suits you very well.”

“Now, what’s your name?” Katsuki asked, getting straight to what he wanted. “I know it’s not Hiroji.”

He burned to know deep down—to wonder what name actually graced the person who had always seemed to pop in and out of his life. Katsuki watched striking green eyes turn into pretty half crescent moons again. The freckled man smiled at him.

The same sweet smile with the same dimples. A genuine one.

“I’m Izuku.”

Izuku.

This time, he knew in his gut it was real as he fell asleep with the sound of a distant violin playing in his head.

Chapter End Notes

I hope you liked it! Please let me know your thoughts and such below :) I love reading you all's comments.

Thanks so much for reading and I hope you all have a great day!

Chapter 3: Enharmonic

Chapter Notes

Hello! Welcome back. First up, thanks so much to the moon of my life, LunaToons on AO3 for proofing and editing like always :') 💕💕

Small notes:

Heights for reference: Katsuki is 6'1'' (185~ cm) and Izuku is 5'8'' (173~ cm)

Small Refresher/footnotes for the fake names in this hotel arc:

Taro Bakugou = Katsuki
Hiroji Bakugou = Izuku
Henry Sekai = Peter Moore.

Okay! Enjoy reading!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter Three — Enharmonic

.

.

.

Katsuki felt like he was free falling in a vast pool of darkness.

It was thick and suffocating. It pulled him deeper into his thoughts and there was nothing he could grasp onto as he wildly flailed his arms. His fingers stretched painfully for anything to give him purchase but the darkness slipped past his skin like black ink.

Part of him vibrated with fear as he fell into the abyss. However, another part of him recognized what was happening: he was dreaming. These types of dreams leaked into his subconscious when he was far into a deep sleep.

He got these dreams frequently—usually of his mother. His mind would curse him of vivid memories of her like he was trapped in reliving her short lived life over and over.

When the feeling of falling finally stopped it was always abrupt.

It felt as though his soul was ruthlessly slammed into the cold ground. But instead of the ground, he was hurled into his seven-year-old body with a snap like someone was breaking

his spine.

Within an instant, the pain gracefully dissolved. Then afterwards, he would be viewing his childhood through his darkly tinted dreams.

The details were always hazy. Faces of the other homeless people were blurred as they gathered around their makeshift shelters. He struggled to remember anyone's name, even the ones he remembered being kind to him.

His frantic eyes looked around desperately as he heard the crunch of snow. This time the dream was winter—other times in the dreams it was summer. This reflected the days he spent alone without his mother. She had disappeared somewhere for nearly a full year when he was seven. All Katsuki could remember past the trauma was being alone, cold and terrified.

Blurry faced men and women were bundled up, gathered around large bins with fire and were tucked in close to each other. The people murmured and stared at him expectantly—but he never knew *what* they were expecting.

Then the dream went the way it always did: with him wandering aimlessly in the falling snow trying to find his mom. In the background, the faint sound of violin music played like a lullaby.

It was always the same hauntingly beautiful melody. The frigid wetness from the snow seeped slowly into his tattered shoes. The bitter bite of the cold made each step harder to take as he fruitlessly searched. He would call out for her in the cold winter with a hoarse voice. The edges of his vision were vignette black and the frost bite gnawed away at his fingertips.

He asked several people to help him, but they all shook their blurry heads and pointed towards the empty plaza.

He looked in the direction of the plaza. Standing in the middle of the open area was a broken water fountain. It was old, built of grey stone and cracked all over. It was a relic of their district's former glory that was brittle and dry now just like the district was. He walked towards it carefully, the sound of violin grew louder as he neared.

Then he came face to face with the source of the sound.

It was an elder man with a white violin. He was standing below a forgotten statue of an angel that was covered in snow. His hair was pure white, and his face was dotted with liver spots. The bags under his eyes were heavy with grief and sadness as he moved the bow of his instrument with deep purpose. Katsuki noted how he was playing as if he was in front of an entire crowd at some grand ball and not the quiet streets of San'ya with an audience of one.

Then Katsuki moved his eyes to the small wooden bench and realized he wasn't the only one there. The violinist was playing for a crowd of two it seemed.

A small boy politely sat on the wooden bench with his eyes trained on the man. He had dark hair and was neatly dressed—someone that young Katsuki would consider rich. He had a

puffy red coat, gloves, yellow scarf and yellow ear muffs to keep him warm. Even his boots were shiny and expensive.

That boy didn't belong here—he was clearly taken care of by someone.

Dream Katsuki looked down at his ragged clothes and he felt a shiver run up his spine. The various holes in his shoes, shirt, and pants were letting all the cold air in as he shook under the harsh winter wind.

He sneezed lightly and the other boy in his dream turned to him.

It was like a dream within a dream as the figure faced him, revealing a white bandage wrapped around one eye. It had dark red blood stained on it, but the other eye was blurred out. The no-faced boy looked down at Katsuki's feet and asked something inaudible.

Katsuki squinted and strained to hear him. Then he crept closer as the boy kept mouthing something to him. Katsuki walked forward until he finally stood right in front of the other boy. Then finally the quiet words became crystal clear. The tiny voice was soft, gentle and caring.

"Are you cold?"

Katsuki tilted his head and like an eerie mirror, the faceless boy did too.

Katsuki scrunched his face as his memory started clearing. Bits and pieces of this dream were false, but the other parts were true. He suddenly remembered in his dream haze that this was a real memory. It was always distant and far out of his reach from being clear.

He stretched his hand up to touch the boy's face in an attempt to feel out what he looked like. However, he was snatched from the depths of his dream by a large shake to his body. He went forcefully toppling to the cold, snow covered ground.

The blurry faced boy repeated his question.

"Are you cold?"

Katsuki fearfully looked around as the dreamscape started crumbling in every direction. Pieces of the fountain caved in on itself, the hard stones shattered to the ground with large reverberations. Dread crackled against Katsuki's nerves as he felt his body shaken again. He was thrusted in the opposite direction of the boy, who was still worried about him.

"Are you cold?"

Katsuki looked up again. This time the statue of the angel began to crumble. A piece of the debris went flying straight for the faceless boy—who didn't move. He only repeated his question like he was stuck on a glitch.

Katsuki screamed and moved to save the boy in front of him from the toppling stones.

"Are you—"

Katsuki's scarlet eyes snapped open, and his body sprung up on the tiny grey couch. He automatically lurched forward, and he went crashing onto the ground when he lost his balance. He felt another body topple downwards with him and a loud groan filled the room. Katsuki's arm extended to grab the figment of the dream that was still hazy in his mind.

He thought he had grabbed the boy—but instead he grabbed something else.

Or someone else.

When Katsuki finally focused he realized he was, in fact, no longer dreaming. Instead, he was very much awake in his new hell, this stupid hotel.

Coupled with that, his hand was currently wrapped around a certain green haired nuisance's throat.

Katsuki took a second to assess their positions. His body was placed on top of the other hitman's. One of his hands was next to the menace's head, and the other was effectively pinning the man down by his throat.

But what threw Katsuki off the most was the fucking near nudeness of the other.

Damp green curls were messy and plastered to his forehead from the water. Plus, his bare chest was on display, the tattoo of the number 217 on his clavicle was clear and there was a skimpy white towel barely wrapped around his waist. It was neatly tucked in at his hips but was dangerously fucking close to exposing what was between the man's smooth legs. Legs that were *wide* fucking open.

And Katsuki's knee was right *there*.

Katsuki groaned and hung his head in defeat.

Yup. He wasn't fucking dreaming anymore.

There was a hint of surprise sprinkled across the other man's freckled face. Then that surprise changed to mild amusement.

Katsuki glowered when the man now identified as Izuku gave a sweet smile. A smile that quickly felt condescending and annoying as shit. Katsuki debated heavily on whether he should remove his hand or choke this motherfucker to death for real. He technically *did* have kill orders on this man.

"Wow. You're really getting into your role as a lover," Izuku teased lightly. "If I didn't know any better, I would say you look like you're going to kiss me."

Katsuki frowned in disgust. "I am *choking* you."

"Not hard enough to be threatening or enjoyable though." Izuku lifted his hands to cover Katsuki's larger one. He squeezed lightly on it to apply some level of pressure. "You have to commit a bit more if you're going to put your hands around my throat like this."

And with that Katsuki snatched his hand backwards like it had been bitten.

“Fucking masochist,” Katsuki muttered under his breath. “Of *course* you’re a fucking masochist.”

A small rush of heat ran down his spine as he noted how his hand had wrapped a little too perfectly around the slender throat.

Still heavy with sleep, Katsuki pushed himself off from the ground and shook his head. That damn Deku slowly lifted himself off the ground too and awkwardly scratched behind his head.

“And good morning to you too,” Izuku said with a small smile. “I thought we would at least get past two days without attempt of murder. Didn’t think it would be immediately the next morning after we gave introductions.”

“It’s your own damn fault, dumbass,” Katsuki bit back unkindly. His red eyes narrowed suspiciously as he remembered the crumbling debris in his dream and how hard his body had shaken. “Why the hell were you so close to me anyways?”

“You were, uh, shaking and muttering a bit in your sleep,” Izuku explained. Green eyes looked him up and down carefully—almost as if he gave a damn. “You seemed like you were having a nightmare of sorts, so I shook you awake.”

“So? Let me have the goddamn nightmare, you weirdo.”

Katsuki scowled. He walked away from the other man, eager to put some distance between them. Katsuki stopped in front of his red suitcase and bent down. He unzipped it a bit harder than needed, letting out some aggression.

The faded pieces of the strange dream were still lingering behind in his mind. It left him in a pensive state as he thought about the nameless boy with the bloodied, bandaged eye from his childhood.

Izuku walked over to him slowly. “I know but—”

“—But *what*?” Katsuki snapped.

He turned his head towards the other. However, an unexpected thump from his heart hit his sternum as he locked eyes with Izuku. Striking green irises were staring at him with a twinge of *care*.

Without notice, his gut twisted with an odd sensation. So, he lashed out.

“Were you worried or some shit, Deku? Mind your fucking business next time and don’t touch me.”

And that seemed to be the switch.

Izuku's eyes drained of all compassion and an invisible wall stacked sky high between them. Izuku straightened his back and pushed his hands down to his side. The sudden flip of emotions would've thrown Katsuki off if he didn't know the doe-eyed man was a trained killer.

"Right," Izuku said stiffly. His eyes skirted off to the side. "You should go ahead and get dressed. I already showered, so the bathroom is all yours."

Izuku turned around and tightened the towel around his waist.

Katsuki struggled to tear his eyes away as he followed the motion of Izuku's hands. The small, fuzzy towel was *barely* covering the other's lower body. Scarlet eyes briefly traced up and down the other's freckled backside and noted all the tiny scars and gunshot wounds. Then his eyes dipped below the hem of the towel.

He blinked once and then blinked twice.

Seeing that ass now, up close and personal, felt bizarre. Usually, it was retreating away from him at full speed but now there it was—barely cladded and in his face. If Izuku was to bend over, even in the *slightest*, he was positive he would get a full view of the other's sensitive areas.

Heat suddenly tickled Katsuki's nape. He quickly tore his eyes away before he could study the other's body any longer.

Focus. He reprimanded himself. *Fucking focus and stop staring at that menace's ass.*

Katsuki reached inside of his suitcase and grabbed his two handguns and usual outfit. He headed towards the bathroom. The air in the bathroom was still dampened with the lingering scent of fresh soap as his foggy mind started to clear up.

Once the green nuisance was out of his head, his thoughts wandered back to his dream as he prepped for his shower. He thought about the crumbling statue of the angel and that violinist.

Katsuki couldn't help but grow disquieted as he stripped himself down.

He climbed into the shower. He let the hot water hit him steadily as he unwillingly reflected on that part of his childhood. Usually his dreams were of his mother these days. Katsuki wondered what the hell triggered such an intense resurgence of that time in his life. He used to be haunted by that song and those dreams when he was a teen, but they had been buried for so long Katsuki hadn't felt any fear about them coming back.

Those dreams were always unpleasant. They were a dark, distorted version of a specific era in his childhood that he struggled with accepting. He always wanted to forget that year happened—but he apparently *couldn't*.

No matter how hard he tried.

It was the year his mother had up and fucking disappeared when he was seven. She had given him a sweet smile, exactly a useless handful of yen and pointed to their makeshift tent of a

home on the street. Katsuki remembered how confused he had been because it was the dead of winter, and she never came back that year.

Katsuki hated that year because it was the year he had to fend for himself. As a child. *Alone*.

Well. Almost alone.

His mind wandered back to the faceless boy in the dream with the bloodied and bandaged eye. Katsuki paused washing his hair for a moment.

What was his name again?

Katsuki used to know it. He had spent a year with the kid but after so much that happened between when he was seven to now, it was hazy. He stared blankly ahead at the shower's white tiled surface. The blurry face in his dream flashed in the front of his mind and he struggled to clear the fog around the boy—

—But before Katsuki could dive deeper in that part of his memory, there was a timid knock on the door.

"Are you swimming in there?" Izuku called out from the other side. "We still need to go purchase rings and if you take any longer, we're going to miss breakfast. I would prefer not to bring any more attention to us from Moore."

"I'm almost fucking done," Katsuki shouted back, fully irritated. "We'll be *fine*! Go sit your antsy ass down."

He grumbled, resumed washing his hair, and buried all thoughts of that year of his childhood. He barely could remember the way that boy looked, much less his name. Like a hundred times before, he vowed again to let it go.

It was damn near pointless to ponder over past things like that. Especially *now*.

This was his last assignment, and if all went right then he could go settle down in a quiet life like he planned. All his past pains would be buried so far deep that he would pretty much be starting a second life.

Katsuki finished showering and getting ready in the bathroom in silence. His nerves were automatically on edge because of who stood on the other side of the door. He wondered how the *fuck* this was going to work considering the closest they've ever been to communicating was via bullets and knives.

Katsuki pulled on a tight black turtleneck. It was one of his favorites because it was thin and defined his built biceps well. Simple but neat enough to give him some level of style and highlight his muscular physique. He paired the shirt with his favorite black pants and sleek black belt to complete the look.

It was a perfect juxtaposition for how goddamn pink the hotel was and gave him a sense of balance. He meticulously combed his blond spikes into a neat formation and then put in his black fang shaped earrings. He finished off his look with his silver chain.

Katsuki sighed as he loaded up his two black pistols bullet by bullet. He cocked them for good measure because there was no way in hell he was going to spend this mission disarmed when his worst nightmare was glued to him. He strapped them securely in his hidden calf holsters under both of his pants' legs.

When he emerged from the bathroom, sitting on the bed looking as patient as a saint was Izuku. Green eyes cut to him and both men froze at the sight of each other.

Katsuki's heart did a peculiar flip.

The first thing he noticed was the tiny Band-Aid covering up Izuku's number tattoo.

The second thing he noticed was the ungodly amount of pink that assaulted his eyes.

Izuku was dressed in a neat, damn near pretty, rose pink shirt that had a white hibiscus flower pattern on it. The shirt itself was unbuttoned, revealing a white tank underneath that was tucked into light khaki-colored shorts. Very fucking *short* shorts. On his feet were pink sneakers and cutesy white socks that were halfway up his calf. The little bastard even had pink heart shaped earrings in. The pink perfectly complimented his dark moss-colored curls.

"You look fucking hideous," Katsuki deadpanned.

Large green eyes blinked rapidly at him as if they were snatched from a daze. Izuku refocused and looked at him with a confused face. His button nose scrunched up.

"Stop staring then," Izuku replied. He then gestured up and down to Katsuki's outfit with an unimpressed expression. "Are you really going to wear that? This is supposed to be a happy place."

"I don't *do* happy, Deku."

"I'll be sure to ask around for the nearest funeral for you to attend."

Katsuki ignored the smart-ass comment and shook his head.

He packed his work out gear for their stupid couple's aerobics later in his small, black backpack. He begrudgingly slung one strap over his shoulder. He put on his sleek black shoes, fully completing his outfit. When he turned around, Katsuki put his hand on his hip impatiently when Izuku continued to stare at him like he was some wild animal.

"You got all the shit you need, Deku? Or are you going to keep staring at me like you have a single brain cell?"

Izuku cleared his throat and snapped his sights away from Katsuki. "Let me get my aerobics clothes."

He watched as Izuku packed up his workout clothes in a tiny yellow backpack. Katsuki scowled deeply because he disliked how fucking *sweet* this man looked right now. His freckles only added to the harmless demeanor and Katsuki wondered if this was part of his ruse as a hitman. Dress like a normal dork to throw everyone around off.

Katsuki watched Izuku place his vintage, pink, heart shaped sunglasses on top of his head of curls like he really *was* on vacation.

Then he watched how the man packed the worn-down book from the previous night in his bag. This was enough to give Katsuki pause in his rampant judgement. He caught a glimpse of the title that was in delicate, romantic lavender lettering: Saishū kōkyōkyoku.

Katsuki tilted his head curiously as Izuku zipped it tight in his backpack.

“Alright, I got everything,” Izuku said with a cheery smile. “Anything else before we go?”

“Yeah, can we discuss how we are going to kill this bastard?” Katsuki asked the obvious question. “Did you have anything in mind specifically?”

“Well, since he knows us now, we can’t do a stealth job.” Izuku tapped his finger on his chin. “We could use this to our advantage though. We can gain his trust and find an opening that way.”

“I agree, we have to befriend him, track his habits and then strike when we’re alone. Possibly a night job and then cover up with alibis.”

“Yeah. I like that. Let’s aim to get him alone and make it look like some sort of suicide or murder-suicide to close the loop. That way police won’t go hunting around for a killer,” Izuku suggested. “I have a list of people in his circle that we could frame. He has an assistant, Minoru Koizumi, who seems to be his right-hand man.”

“You want to try to set him up?”

“If possible, yes.” Izuku nodded, his deep green eyes were very serious as he stared at the wall in deep thought. “Koizumi knows a lot about Moore’s trafficking operations. It would be a believable story for the police that they turned on each other at their headquarters.”

“So, the stage will be his headquarters then.”

“Yes. My handler called for all his underground operations to come to light. A murder-suicide at their operation grounds would be ideal.”

“Do you know where those grounds are?”

“Somewhere in the Okinawa area. The hotel is a ruse to lure victims in, but his HQ is reportedly nearby to get them sorted into the underground. We just have to find it.”

Katsuki disliked admitting it, but he liked the way Izuku thought.

It could work. It could work very well. The only issue Katsuki worried about was the detail of being overly friendly with Peter Moore. That required them acting like the perfect couple to the point the bastard would let his guard down.

The idea of pretending to be in love made Katsuki’s chest twist bitterly. He sucked in a deep breath and pushed down all his worries. Last assignment. This was his last assignment—he

could do it. Fake being in love, and he was set for the rest of his life.

“Alright. Murder-suicide at his HQ it is,” Katsuki said decidedly. “Let’s head out and get started.”

☽ ☽ ☽

They walked towards the downtown area of Nago, Okinawa that they were located in.

The scene itself was beautiful. Katsuki had to give Peter Moore credit for the location he settled in. This was truly the perfect spot for a hotel that was targeted towards lovesick couples and singles. The fluffy white clouds in the sky were gently floating above them, mimicking the texture of cotton candy that was soft enough to touch and even taste. The blue ocean next to them was sparkling with the tiny rays of light it caught in its waves.

Katsuki listened to Izuku hum lightly and couldn’t help but realize the weirdo was harmonizing with the distant sound of wind chimes. He would’ve said something along the lines of ‘shut the hell up’ or ‘be quiet’ just to get under the man’s skin—but Izuku’s light humming was actually decent.

It was a gentle melody, and it lulled a part of Katsuki’s angry spirit. He cut his eyes to the man next to him to study him closely out of instinct. Large, green eyes were taking in all the various sights as they walked past the docks. Different sized boats were stationed all around with fishermen, captains and tourists all geared up to go to the different islands around Okinawa.

They passed by one particular dock that had a large, white arc at the beginning. It was decorated in pretty, green leaves and sitting at the top was the symbol of a white dove. The animal of purity was carrying an olive branch.

Katsuki raised a curious brow at the large, all white cruise boat. It was big enough for at least one hundred folks.

“The White Dove,” Izuku said as he read the gold text underneath the image of the dove. They passed by the port a little slower when they noted how this boat had a line wrapped around to the other side. “I wonder where that boat goes. Maybe we can check it out if there’s down time later.”

Katsuki snorted and rolled his eyes.

“There is no fucking ‘*we’*,” he reminded unkindly. “The only reason my foot isn’t up your ass is because we share a mark and got roped into this bullshit together. I can’t afford to blow this, so I’m stomaching all this crap the best I can. This is not a vacation.”

“But it might as well be! I mean look around, this place is really beautiful,” Izuku said with a curl of excitement at the end. His doe eyes laid sights on all the lush greenery that held delicate, tiny flowers. He grinned up at the pink blossoms in the trees above them. “C’mon you have to be enjoying this. Unless you've already been here before?”

“No, this is my first time,” Katsuki said. He admired the setting too, despite himself. “But you’re right. It is beautiful. That trafficking bastard has good taste.”

Katsuki adjusted his black sunglasses on his face as he caught the eye of several people. They looked him up and down, probably confused by his all-black outfit. He scowled at them instantly and took pleasure in the way the nosy extras quickly averted their gaze. Katsuki gave a delighted, wicked smirk.

Red eyes then turned their targets on the humming hitman next to him.

“So how about you, Deku?” Katsuki asked. “Have you been here before?”

“Ah, nope! This is my first time as well,” Izuku offered up casually. He skipped slightly in his step. Bubbly. Bubbly as fucking ever. “I’ve read about this place a lot though! Which makes me excited to be here.”

“Does that little book of yours happen to take place here?”

Izuku spluttered slightly in surprise. Wide eyes rounded on him, and dark green eyebrows were raised up all the way in surprise.

“What? Don’t act so surprised,” Katsuki commented. “I saw you hide that ratty thing in your backpack like you were tucking it in a little hidey hole.”

He tilted his head at how goddamn strange Izuku was acting over the mention of the book. Then when Izuku blushed, it clicked. A cruel smirk twitched its way on Katsuki’s face at the thought.

“It *does* take place here, doesn’t it, Deku?”

“Erm, yeah,” Izuku admitted as he rubbed his nape. Blush the same color as his shirt crept all the way up from his collarbone to his cheeks. “I-It’s my favorite book. I was really happy to take this assignment when it was offered to us.”

“Oh, this is fucking *gold*.” Katsuki snickered and grinned down at the shorter man. “Please don’t tell me it’s some sappy romance novel. That would be fucking hilarious for someone like you to be reading a love story.”

Izuku paused slightly, slowing his pace. His eyebrows furrowed as he looked at Katsuki.

“Someone like...me?”

“Yeah. Y’know.” Katsuki gestured between the two of them like it was obvious. “Someone like *us*.” He whispered the last part as if the unsaid words would hang in the air.

Killers. Assassins. Hitmen.

Surely even damn Deku had to understand what he was talking about: people like them who *clearly* shouldn’t fucking fall in love or buy into romantic propaganda. Katsuki sure as hell

didn't. And given Izuku was the only person he knew who could best him, he assumed the other hitman had enough sense not to believe in something as fickle as love.

"What if it was a romance story?" Izuku said carefully. "Would that be so bad?"

"That would be fucking *rich* coming from you," Katsuki retorted without thinking. "Don't tell me you're a hopeless romantic for real?"

He turned his eyes ahead of them looking critically at all the couples walking by. They were all holding hands in the morning light. A small bitter piece of him twisted at the sight.

Katsuki waited a moment for some smart-ass response—but he got silence in return.

He finally looked down beside him to see Izuku looking longingly at the couples. Izuku slowly folded his arms in a protective way and then pursed his lips. He glanced down to the stone pavement quietly as they walked and slowed his pace. Katsuki slowed down his stride automatically with Izuku's.

"Wait. Are you?" Katsuki asked a bit more seriously.

His eyebrows raised to the sky, not expecting to hit *that* on the head.

He shouldn't care. Katsuki had been bumping into Izuku for years, but he only knew the man's personal choice of gun and knife. But now, the layers of Izuku's bubbly personality were becoming exposed rather rapidly. But fuck—Deku—deadly fucking Deku—a possible *hopeless romantic*?

His curiosity prickled dangerously as he looked at the silky head of curls.

"Hey," Katsuki probed again when Izuku didn't answer. "Deku. Are you deaf? I asked you a question—"

"—And I'm choosing not to answer if you're going to poke fun at me," Izuku snapped. There was a deep blush of embarrassment on the shorter man's face as he tightened his folded arms protectively. "It's none of your business anyways. Let's hurry up and get the rings so we can go eat."

The sudden shift in demeanor made Katsuki raise a brow. Izuku's bubbly aura deflated into something sour that surprisingly stung Katsuki.

Katsuki opened his mouth to say more but Izuku started walking quickly until he was ahead of him. The shorter man beelined right towards the nearest jewelry store without sparing him a single glance. Red eyes blinked rapidly at the sudden blow off. There wasn't even some hint of sassy retort just a flat out: fuck off.

Katsuki's chest twisted with something he didn't dare to name.

He frowned and followed behind Izuku until they both were in front of the shiny section of rings. He noted how Izuku looked visibly bristled. Extremely so. Katsuki watched as green

eyes traced up and down the different items as if looking for the right fake wedding rings in his pissed off state.

“Let’s buy whatever,” Izuku grumbled. He still didn’t look at Katsuki and for some reason it slightly bothered him. “It doesn’t matter what we pick, I guess.”

Katsuki frowned deeply as he slightly bent at the waist to lean down to the other man’s height.

“...You know I’m joking, right?” Katsuki tried to back track. “It doesn’t matter if it’s a romance novel or whatever.”

He licked his chapped lips. He felt a bit ridiculous trying to coddle a man who had no issue holding a knife to his jugular less than a week ago. Katsuki told himself that he didn’t *really* care if Izuku was upset—but he reasoned that he didn’t need the other hitman to be pissed with him during this assignment.

When it boiled down to it, they still had to pretend to like each other.

“It’s fine,” Izuku muttered, turning away from him. The irritated air around him melted into something resigned with an underlying sadness. “Let’s choose the rings. I’m sure some plain gold bands will do just fine.”

Katsuki pressed his tongue to the side of his cheek to hold back a comment.

It was so damn obvious whatever he said about the romance shit was bothering Izuku. He guessed his inquiry was right. Damn Deku was a hopeless romantic and he was fucking *sensitive* about it.

Katsuki huffed through his nose. He grew annoyed the longer he studied Izuku’s closed off body language. He didn’t need this damn dork in a sullen mood when they had to go to breakfast *and* aerobics. He needed this motherfucker to go back to skipping and in his little Lala-Deku world. If he was visibly saddened that was surely going to raise eyebrows—right?

Katsuki eyed the assortment of rings.

“How about those ones?” Katsuki said with slight reluctancy. He pointed with his thumb to the rings with gems in them off to the side. Izuku frowned and followed the gesture, surprised to see where Katsuki was pointing. “We could, er, get the ones with gems in it. Green for me and red for you.”

Izuku stared at him, baffled. “Red and green for our favorite colors?”

“No, dumbass. Green and red for our *eyes*,” Katsuki hissed impatiently. He was attempting to be nice but not that nice. “It would sell the whole fake husbands bullshit if we went the super mushy route, right? I can wear the green one and you wear the red one. We’ll say it’s to keep a piece of the other with us at all times or something.”

“Are you sure you’re not a romance novel lover as well?” Izuku’s cold demeanor thawed with a tiny twitch of a smile. “That sounds like something straight out of a book I’ve read

before."

"Oh, shut the hell up, dipshit, and let's buy the rings." Katsuki glowered in an attempt to hide the blush that rushed to his cheeks. "You're getting on my last fucking nerve and it's not even the afternoon yet."

"Alright alright." Izuku laughed lightly and Katsuki hated how melodic it sounded. "We can get the green and red ones. You're right, the mushy route works well."

They continued and picked out the rings. Katsuki grabbed the black gold wedding band that had a strip of rich jade gems sandwiched in the center. He held it up to Izuku's eyes and the other hitman looked at him surprised a bit. Then Izuku realized what Katsuki was doing and stood still with his hands patiently clasped together in front of him. He stared directly into Katsuki's eyes.

Another unannounced thump against his chest occurred.

Katsuki swallowed as they made eye contact for the first time without deadly intentions.

Izuku looked shy as he struggled to maintain eye contact with Katsuki. A small pink colored blush appeared across his freckled face. He held up the jade encrusted ring next to Izuku's eyes.

Katsuki tilted his head as he glanced back and forth between Izuku's doe eyes and the ring.

"Not quite," Katsuki muttered without breaking eye contact.

It wasn't the right shade. Sure, there were bits and pieces of jade and light green sprinkled inside of Izuku's eyes like stupid little stars, but the base color was deeper—more earthy and rich. He had come to know those lethal eyes well the last eight years. If he wanted to, he could probably list five different shades of green that Izuku's eyes held.

But there was no way in hell he was going to do that in this lifetime.

Katsuki inwardly cursed himself when his heart sped up a bit at the same moment Izuku gave a shy smile. He quickly put down the ring in his hand and turned again to the selection. He searched over the green hues carefully until one caught his eye. This time Katsuki reached for the black gold ring with shining emeralds encrusted in the center.

He held it up to Izuku's eyes in the same fashion as the last.

His breath nearly hitched. The gems exactly resembled the deep green irises staring at him.

"Perfect match," Katsuki said quietly.

He lowered the ring slightly as they stared at each other for a moment. *Pretty*. Izuku's eyes were still so fucking pretty up-close after all these years since Vienna.

This time when Izuku smiled at him, Katsuki felt an odd flip in his chest again. It was close to the feeling he felt in Vienna and made him disgruntled that such a feeling was bubbling

inside of him again. But because of how light and fluttering it felt, Katsuki buried it deep.

He cleared his throat, successfully breaking the moment and unceremoniously waved his hand towards the rings again.

“Your turn, Deku,” Katsuki said without too much bite.

Izuku took one quick look at Katsuki’s eyes and then reached for a matching black gold ring that had deep colored ruby gems inside the middle. He held it up to Katsuki’s eyes for a moment before his face split wide with a toothy smile.

“Got it,” Izuku said cheerfully.

Katsuki furrowed his brow at the quickness. “What? On the first try?”

“Yeah. I think I know your eyes well enough by now to pick out the right gems to match,” Izuku said casually, confusing the other.

Katsuki stammered as he thought about what Izuku had proclaimed.

What the fuck does he mean he knows my eyes?

Katsuki was going to ask just what the hell did *that* mean, but he was left a little speechless by the fact Izuku apparently had his exact shade of red memorized. He almost felt a smidge bit guilty about how it took him two tries to get Izuku’s eye color—but he shook his head at the thought quickly. That type of shit didn’t matter.

Izuku smiled tightly and spun on his heels towards the counter.

He’s odd. Katsuki said to himself when that stupid fluttering feeling slithered under his skin again. *Ignore him, he’s a hopeless romantic weirdo who has shot you several times.*

They checked out at the counter with little conversation as a new atmosphere bubbled around them. Katsuki didn’t miss the way Izuku seemed nearly happy to have the ring. The dork stared at it like it was something he only ever imagined in his wildest dreams. There was a twinge of reservation in that freckled face, but Katsuki could see straight through the facade. Izuku was happy about getting the red and green rings.

They both slid the new jewelry on their ring fingers and the weight of it tethered Katsuki to reality. Izuku stared for a moment at his ruby encrusted ring, before blinking rapidly. He flashed Katsuki a fake smile before gesturing to head back to the hotel.

Katsuki quietly looked down at his ring then to his pretend husband.

☽ ☽ ☽

The new weight on his hand felt heavy with the implication that this dumb situation was very real.

They made their way back to the hotel and all around them, more people were up and about. The couples and singles in the hotel had officially risen awake to begin another ignorantly happy day.

Him and Izuku made their way to the dining hall and like the last time they were inside, Katsuki couldn't help but study the painted angels on the ceiling. Particularly the one section off to the corner that he noticed the last time.

He stared at the visual of the limp, dead man in the weeping angel's arms.

The same unsettling feeling washed over Katsuki the longer he stared at it above the heads of all the happy people. But unlike last night's dinner, in the background there was a small orchestra playing classical music. The flow of the strings, wind instruments and piano were pleasant to Katsuki's ears as he and Izuku made their way to their designated table.

Franz Liszt, Liebestraum. Love Dream, Katsuki casually thought to himself when the melody became clearer. He nodded slightly to the seated mini orchestra with an approving look. *Good choice. Seems like everything here isn't utterly tacky.*

From a distance Katsuki could already see their circus of colorful assigned friends. Loud ass fire truck red hair, bubble gum pink and a two-toned bowl cut stood out from the distance. They were all already chatting it seemed like. A tiny hand from Jirou in the distance waved at the two of them. Both hitmen gave tiny waves back.

There's our dumb ass crew.

As they patiently waited to get to the front of the line, Katsuki watched how Izuku studied all the various couples around. Or more specifically, he studied their interlocked fingers.

"Maybe we should hold hands," Izuku suggested nervously as he glanced around. "We look like we barely like each other."

"We *do* barely like each other," Katsuki deadpanned as he crossed his arms. "I've had to stop myself from gagging twice this morning at the sight of you."

"You know what I mean," Izuku whispered quietly with a twinge of annoyance. "We should hold hands to blend in more."

"No," Katsuki aggressively whispered back. "We don't need to be one of those disgusting PDA couples—"

"—Just do it, *Taro*."

Katsuki was about to belt out a loud 'fuck off, Hiroji' but he stopped when Izuku unhappily gestured to the different pairs surrounding them. They were indeed the only ones not being lovey dovey. Everyone else was making gushy eyes at each other so hard that Katsuki could practically see the invisible cartoon hearts floating around them.

Katsuki groaned.

Fuck this. Fuck this six ways and back. He was an assassin *goddamnit*. Hell, he was fucking known as The Scarlet Eyed Killer—he shouldn't be subjected to *this*.

He stared down at Izuku resentfully.

"Don't make it weird," Katsuki hissed from behind his clenched teeth. He narrowed his eyes. "If you make it weird, I'm going to punch you right here and now."

He held his hand open and Izuku took it.

They stumbled for a bit to get it right. First, they both squeezed too tightly. Katsuki nearly crushed Izuku's small hand in his. Then they messed up interlocking their fingers over and over to the point it began to look clumsy as they stood in line for food.

Several people turned their way as they lightly bickered back and forth until finally Izuku huffed. The green-eyed man shot his other hand out and seized Katsuki's wrist impatiently. He held it steady and then Izuku carefully slotted their fingers together and gripped tightly.

Warm. That was Katsuki's first thought as they dropped the struggle and finally held hands.

His second thought was that he hated how he was possibly blushing. Katsuki had never held hands with anyone—not since he was a fucking kid.

The gesture was too intimate. Good for the facade they were putting on, but bad for his anti-romantic heart. He could feel that there were calluses on Izuku's palm, matching in the exact same places as his—but the skin on top of his hand felt nearly delicate. *Soft*.

"Now, was that so bad?" Izuku grumbled as they walked together in line.

"I feel a little piece of my soul dying as we speak."

"You're so melodramatic."

He nearly snatched his hand back when Izuku squeezed it lightly.

They grabbed their plates of buffet style breakfast food before walking over to their round table. Hand in fucking hand. Much to Katsuki's displeasure, it seemed like Mina, Momo, and Shouto were ecstatic to see them.

"Taro! Hiroji!" Mina greeted them with a wide grin. "Good morning you two love birds! How did you sleep?"

Like hell.

"Like we were on a cloud," Katsuki lied through his teeth. "How about you guys?"

And that offset the conversation as they settled down in their chairs with their porcelain plates.

Everyone began talking about things that Katsuki didn't care to listen to. He tuned them out, thinking of ways to stage their eventual murder-suicide as Momo blabbered something about the sky being gorgeous last night. Then her girlfriend, Jirou, reinforced it while Shouto and Inasa nodded in agreement with them. The conversation kept going for a long time as Katsuki fell into his role as stoic husband to Izuku's social butterfly personality.

Katsuki stared around casually until he caught sight of the hotel owner. He smirked slightly as the man waved to him and Katsuki motioned him over to their table.

Time to be friends with this fucker.

Moore grinned as he walked over in his white suit to their table.

"Good morning to my favorite couple!" Moore beamed at them. He clasped his large hands down on Izuku's shoulders, leaning over him slightly. "Sorry, everyone else. These two take the cake for me."

"It's no problem," Shouto said as he took a bite of a helping of vegetables. "They are quite a pair."

"I wanted to ask, how was your night in the honeymoon suite, Bakugous?" Moore asked. He glanced between him and Izuku happily with a smirk. "Did you two enjoy the jacuzzi bathtub? I recently had those installed and want to see how people liked them."

Katsuki didn't even fucking know there was one.

"Yeah, it was really relaxing! We took a bubble bath together last night," Izuku chimed happily. What a little fucking liar. "Please, sit down with us. I wanted to chat with you about decorations. How did you come up with the interior design for this place? I want to do something like this for our house."

The hotel owner sat down on the other side of Izuku in the empty chair. Then like magic, the two blended into conversation.

Katsuki had to resist the urge to roll his eyes. He was thankful he didn't live with Izuku for real as the man began to exchange specific pastel colors with Moore.

Magic mint? *Persian pastel*? Katsuki held back a gag.

As his faux husband lured in their prey with his freckled smile, Katsuki turned his eyes up to the painting of the angels above them. He briefly looked at the captivating, crystal chandelier before focusing all the way on the image.

It seemed to follow a circle pattern around the dome shaped ceiling, the same two figures appeared throughout. One was clearly an angel, and the other person was wingless. His eyes studied all the background angels and how gentle the scene looked.

He followed the motion of the panels. The first was of two figures dancing together under the stars, then another of them flying high together, seemingly in love. Then he skipped over the middle a bit to finally land on that disturbing bit off to the side.

“I see you’ve taken an interest in the painting above, Taro,” Moore cut into his thoughts. Katsuki turned to the man whose expression was now vastly different—more pensive. “I commissioned it myself. It tells of this story I heard as a kid about two lovers.”

“What’s the story’s name?” Katsuki asked curiously.

“Ah, I can’t recall the name personally.” Moore shrugged. Everyone’s eyes then turned up to the extravagant painting. “It was told to me as a child, so bits of it escaped me and I could never come across it again. Its morals stuck with my psyche so much that when I opened this place, I wanted to put it up in hopes maybe someone would recognize it.”

“I have never heard of anything resembling this,” Inasa said. The large man slung his arm over Shouto’s shoulder and tilted his head. “What’s it about?”

“It’s the love story of an angel and a sinner human,” Moore explained. “The painting shows them meeting, falling in love, and how other angels watched them care for each other.”

Katsuki eyed the last panel that was riddled with death.

“What’s with that part right there?” Katsuki asked carefully. He pointed to the part his eyes kept wandering back to. “It’s different from the rest.”

“Ah, great eye, Taro! That part tells the end of the story.” Moore’s voice grew quiet, drawing everyone’s attention in. “After the human falls in love with the beautiful angel, he asks to receive a potion that would turn him into an angel. This way he could grow wings and join his lover in eternity.”

“Wow,” Mina said with a dreamy look. “Changing who you are to fly away with the person you love. So sweet!”

“At this point in the story, yes.” Moore interrupted. He clasped his hands together while his eyes never left the last panel. “Unfortunately, it turned out the angel was an angel of death—not love. The angel was sent to collect the human’s soul for hell but fell in love along the way. So, when the time came, instead of delivering a potion that would turn the human into an angel, he gave him a red apple injected with viper venom. It ends his lover’s life.”

Katsuki paused his eating.

He tore his eyes away from the haunting painting to the man next to him who continued speaking.

“The angel weeps because he did truly love the human. However, nothing could be done as he watched all the life drain from his lover’s face,” Moore finished. He strummed his fingers on his thigh thoughtfully. “The human spends eternity in hell. Then the story ends there.”

“That’s...dark,” Kirishima whispered. “I have to admit I thought it would be a happy ending.”

Katsuki glanced up to the weeping angel.

“Seems a little off brand for the whole romantic paradise theme,” Katsuki said suspiciously. “What kind of moral is behind some fucked up shit like that?”

“That sometimes the person you love is also the same reason for your demise,” Moore explained. “We never truly know another person—only what they show us.”

No one said anything.

Katsuki had to admit he didn’t hate it.

It popped the bubble of stupid love sickness that everyone seemed to be stuck in. The story was realistic and tragic—exactly how Katsuki viewed the world: full of tragedy. No amount of pink, happy go lucky, cheerful shit could hide that. It seemed like even Peter fucking Moore understood.

Katsuki curiously glanced at Izuku who had stayed quiet through the story. The freckled man was staring at the green vile of poison and the red apple in the painting. Suddenly the eyes of the angels looking down at them didn’t feel the same.

“Well! Thank you so much for indulging me in that but I have to start making my rounds,” Moore said. “Time to get back to business. I’m a busy man.”

A pensive state washed over all the couples at the table as Moore rose from his seat. He smoothed out the subtle wrinkles in his white suit and gave everyone a taut smile. He said his goodbyes and bowed out.

“I could’ve gone my whole life without knowing that grim story,” Jirou said in an unimpressed voice. “Why would he say that? He ruined the happy mood. I prefer my PTO to be used for joy, not gloom.”

“Henry Sekai is an interesting man,” Shouto said curtly. He shrugged as he took another bite of his breakfast. “Makes you wonder what his inspiration for opening up this hotel is.”

There was just enough of a hint of suspicion in Shouto’s voice to make Katsuki raise a brow at him. Izuku and Katsuki knew the hotel was a facade for covering up human trafficking—but the tone of voice Shouto used seemed as though he found the whole set up odd as well.

“Well, let’s go reset our energy!” Kirishima said cheerfully. He clapped his hands together with a toothy grin. “No bad energy my dudes! We have a great group and I want to make sure we all have an awesome trip. Are you guys ready for aerobics, Paradise crew?”

“Yeah,” Izuku said with a charming smile. “I’ve never done aerobics before so I’m super excited!”

“Well, if you need any help, little man, let me or Mina know,” Kirishima chuckled. He proudly wrapped his arm around his wife’s shoulders and gazed at her lovingly. “We’re personal trainers for some of the top athletes in Japan!”

“We even have our own couple’s workout DVD coming soon,” Mina said with a thumbs up. “If you guys want, we can put you on the pre-order list. It’s entitled ‘Manliness: A Word for

Everyone'."

"That's a shitty title," Katsuki said in a flat tone. "Who the fuck would buy that—"

Izuku, with all his strength, discreetly stepped on Katsuki's foot under the table without dropping his sun bright smile. The pain immediately stopped Katsuki's sentence midway. Red eyes bulged wide, and Katsuki clenched his teeth to stop from screaming.

"What Taro means is that's a lovely title," Izuku said with a false giggle. "He has a backwards sense of humor. I think my dear husband forgets that not everyone knows his comedy. Isn't that right, *Taro*?"

His fake name was dripped in a threat.

Katsuki sarcastically smiled back. "Right. Just think of me as always participating in 'opposite day.' If I insult you, it means I like you."

Everyone at the table laughed and Katsuki and Izuku cut their eyes towards each other.

☽ ☽ ☽

"New rule, no being an asshole to the other couples," Izuku whispered under his breath as they made their way into the men's locker room at the gym. "We want to paint a picture that we, The Bakugous, are *likable*. We don't need Moore catching wind that we're patronizing the other guests."

Katsuki waved him off. "Yeah yeah, I get you. Quit your bitching."

All of this is annoying as shit, Katsuki thought to himself as he lazily sat on the wooden bench next to Izuku. Everyone around them started shuffling out of their day clothes into work out gear. The two hitmen waited until the other people in the room cleared out and it was only the two of them.

Once the door shut, Katsuki immediately hiked up his shorts and pulled out his two guns.

Izuku looked between him and the loaded guns carefully. "You were strapped this whole time?"

Katsuki hummed lightly and clicked the safety on both of his guns, carefully inspecting them. "I'm always strapped, Deku. You're telling me you're not?"

Green eyes flicked down to Katsuki's baggy shorts as if wondering what else was hiding underneath.

"I am. But not with handguns."

Katsuki raised an eyebrow at the comment—curiosity officially piqued.

He cut his eyes to Izuku as he tucked his guns in his backpack.

As they both began to strip down, Katsuki didn't really have shame about watching Izuku out of the corner of his eye. The curly haired hitman rid himself of those ugly pink clothes and revealed his freckled, well-defined body. Izuku didn't make a move to cover up as red eyes traced over his soft belly and thighs.

When Izuku was down to only his underwear, Katsuki was only partially surprised to see the man's upper thighs and ankles lined with knives. To top it off, there was a thin leather harness belt strapped to his upper body that contained knives as well. All the weapons were small, sharp and deadly. Each one was carefully capped to not poke Izuku. The black straps of the holsters and harness were tight. *Really* fucking tight. They gripped the soft freckled skin in a way that made Katsuki stare a little too hard at the tiny bit of spill over.

He cleared his throat and hurriedly turned around. Katsuki pulled his black muscle tank over his head and stepped into his loose-fitting black shorts quickly. He decided this was dangerous territory when he realized just how fucking squeezable Izuku looked.

But when he turned around, he was not expecting to see that perky ass sliding into skintight stirrup leggings with no underwear.

Katsuki stumbled hard, taken off guard. The leggings finished pulling over with a loud snap and Izuku's ass lightly jiggled.

He tilted his head to look from another angle.

How did that ass look even *better* in leggings? How the hell was that even *fair*? Katsuki briefly wondered if it felt as soft and bitable as it looked. He continued to stare at Izuku's backside as the man pulled a pastel green tank over his head.

"Alright—let's hurry and get out to the—" Izuku suddenly turned around to face him and Katsuki quickly snapped his head upwards. But when he made eye contact with Izuku, green eyes were wide with surprise. "—G-Gym."

Shit.

Izuku's face went up in flames.

"W-Were you just staring at my—"

"—Let's go," Katsuki quickly cut off and headed towards the door.

He turned away to hide his blush when all the blood flooded to his cheeks. Izuku hesitantly followed behind as they walked towards the loud studio area of the gym.

Fuck. Katsuki reprimanded himself. *New rule for yourself, don't stare at that menace's ass. No matter how grabbable it looks.*

When they finally entered the dance studio, couples and singles were stretching, doing warmups together. The loud music was blasting through the speakers perched in all four corners of the room. It vibrated through both of their cores and the energy of everyone else was way too damn high for Katsuki's tastes.

A teal haired woman, who Katsuki assumed to be the instructor, was in the front chatting with Kirishima and Mina—and holy hell was it a sight to behold.

Mina and Kirishima were in matching red and pink unitards that read '*man*—' on Kirishima's ass and '*—liness'* across Mina's in bright, yellow font.

"You've *got* to be shitting me," Katsuki mumbled quietly from beside Izuku.

The two grabbed magenta yoga mats and set up towards the far back corner of the room. Both men did light stretches as they waited for the class to start. It took all Katsuki's decade worth of self-control training not to dip his gaze below Izuku's waistline. The little fucking green nymph bent at the waist and grabbed his toes—unknowingly reminding Katsuki that he was extremely flexible.

"Alrighty everybody!" The instructor's loud voice boomed. Her grin was as bright as a full moon. "Welcome to Couple's Aerobics 101! My name is Fukukado Emi and I'm going to be your instructor this morning! People like to call me Ms. Joke because I find myself being a comedian halfway through these sessions."

She tied her sea-green hair up into a tight bun and wrapped an orange sweatband to her forehead.

"Now let's get started with some basic reps!" She clapped her hands together. "This helps get the blood pumping and rejuvenate and/or build trust with your partner!"

Katsuki and Izuku both visibly winced at the word 'trust'.

"Now, turn to your partner and we're going to dive right into ten reps of squat arm rotations," Emi said enthusiastically. Katsuki and Izuku both turned to each other with awkward stares. "You're going to squat down holding on to the other with one hand. You're going to lean back and put all your weight and trust into your interlocked hands as you go down for a squat in unison! Then when you come up, you quickly switch hands and then squat again."

"Seems simple enough," Izuku said softly. More so to himself than to Katsuki. "We got this. We can do this."

"Just don't fall on me, dipshit," Katsuki said loudly. His belittling comment drew the eyes of several other people close to them.

"Make sure to lean all the way back!" Emi said happily. "The strength of your love will keep you together!"

They both turned towards each other and hesitantly reached out a hand. They grabbed hands and did as they were instructed. The pair squatted low in unison and Katsuki could see the immense concentration glued on Izuku's face. They leaned back in the squat, all the weight and trust in the other balancing them out. The two hitmen successfully did three reps, the flow going seemingly easily.

However, when they squatted all the way down on the fourth rep, Katsuki's eyes snaked to Izuku's outlined crotch. In the moment, slightly distracted when they squatted upright to switch hands again—Katsuki missed grabbing Izuku's hand as the man leaned all the way back once more.

Katsuki cursed loudly, stumbled on his feet but caught himself. However, Izuku did not catch his balance. Green eyes bulged, Izuku yelped, and the short man went toppling backwards in surprise.

Izuku accidentally fell directly into another couple beside them. The pair also cried out surprised yells as they were thrown off balance and fell to the ground as well. It was like a cringe chain reaction as everyone looked back to their corner to see what all the noise was about.

Katsuki gave a faux apologetic expression when Ms. Jokester, or whatever she called herself, gave them a confused glance.

"Is everything alright back there?" She asked over the music.

"Yeah, peachy keen," Katsuki called back and gave a thumbs up. "My husband is just a dumbass clutz."

"O-Oh, alright then!" She glanced between them wearily.

Blazed green eyes glared at him as Izuku brushed himself off and slowly got back up.

"You better fucking watch it and make sure to grab my hand next time, dumbass," Katsuki said and covered up the fact he was staring at Izuku's crotch.

Izuku bristled slightly. "But it was *you* who missed—"

"—I have no damn clue what you're talking about. Now let's get started again."

Izuku stared at him in disbelief as he nursed where he fell on his bottom.

They continued like this—clumsily bickering back and forth. Because who would've *guessed* him and Izuku had terrible fucking trust issues? Even while doing something as simple as paired bicycle crunches.

Izuku barely trusted him to do basic things. The tiny hitman would overcompensate by holding all his own weight in some of the more aerodynamic poses. This caused them to be all off balance and fall to the ground. Over and fucking *over*. Coupled with that, Katsuki was clumsily tossing the smaller hitman around whenever it was time to switch positions.

This behavior earned them several confused—and concerned—stares over the hour.

Inasa and Shouto looked behind several times to catch a glimpse of their mayhem. The onlooking was especially strong when Katsuki hissed 'you clumsy fucker, you kicked me in the face' and pushed Izuku to the ground. But of course, Izuku caught himself easily and would yell back 'stop tossing me around like that!'.

In short, they were a disaster.

“Alright! Last position!” Emi called out. “This one is easy so don’t worry!”

Everyone else in the room around them seemed to groan in happiness, tuckered out from the full-blown workout. Most of the room was huffing, fanning themselves or their partner.

In full contrast to this, he and Izuku hadn’t broken a sweat. This came close to nothing in Katsuki’s normal workout routine—and it seemed like it was nothing for Izuku too. The only other people in the room that seemed to have not broken a sweat were Mina and Kirishima—for obvious reason as he stared at the lettering on their asses. But also, it seemed like Shouto and Inasa didn’t break a sweat either.

“We’re going to do wheelbarrow squats!” Emi said joyfully. “This is one of my favorites because it really gets the intimate connection sparked! You’re going to have one of you get on the floor as the wheelbarrow while the other puts the wheelbarrow’s ankles on their shoulders. The person standing will squat low and do ten reps. You guys can pair positions how you want, but this usually works best with the most flexible person as the wheelbarrow.”

Everyone started getting in position, but neither hitman moved.

Katsuki turned to Izuku expectantly and Izuku looked up at him, puzzled.

“You heard her. Get on the bottom, Deku.” He pointed to the ground beneath his feet.

Izuku scrunched his nose. “Wait, what—*ah*!”

Katsuki impatiently grabbed Izuku by his upper arm and tossed the man to the ground with most of his strength. The green menace went tumbling down, and Katsuki would’ve been worried if not for Izuku’s lightning fucking reflexes.

The freckled hitman caught himself effortlessly in a plank before his face could hit the ground.

Izuku glared up at Katsuki again who gave a sarcastic sneer in return.

Katsuki grumbled to himself as he bent down to the ground. He grabbed Izuku’s locked together ankles and wrapped his fingers all the way around. He forcefully tugged them apart. Out of sheer reflex—and possibly spite—Izuku snapped them back shut.

Katsuki raised a brow before tightening his grip around the slender ankles.

“Spread ‘em,” he said in a low voice.

From this angle, Katsuki could see Izuku blush deeply.

Izuku slowly readjusted himself and relaxed his body. Then Katsuki pulled his legs apart from behind. Katsuki easily hoisted both of Izuku’s legs up by his ankles until he stood tall between them. When he was at full height, they were officially in the wheelbarrow position

with Izuku's shirt riding slowly up. The small of Izuku's back was showing for him and all its freckles too.

Katsuki could see Izuku's blushing nape as he hung his head in defeat. Katsuki couldn't help the comment that left his smirking lips at the sight.

"Is this position familiar for you?"

"Please. S-Shut up." Izuku blushed and hid his face more. "I'm begging you. *Shut up.*"

He decided that teasing Izuku was fucking hilarious. It nearly felt like revenge for the last eight years of hardship.

Katsuki resisted the cruel chuckle that tickled at his lips.

He refocused and placed either one of Izuku's ankles on his shoulders and began to squat low with the counting of the instructor. At first, he kept his eyes straight ahead. Then by the fourth rep, he looked down to see how the humiliated Izuku was fairing. But the flimsy workout tank had ridden up nearly to Izuku's neck.

A bare skinned back full of blush and freckles filled Katsuki's sight. He squatted low again, but this time his eyes automatically moved to the dangerous ass in front of him.

He tried to not let it get to him.

Katsuki always knew he had an Achilles' heel for innocent looking guys in skimpy clothes. But it was conflicting as all hell to see Izuku somehow fit that category.

On one hand, he couldn't stand the man. His smart-ass mouth was one of the most irritating things on this planet. Plus, Katsuki was still very much bitter about Izuku killing Rin Hiryu in front of him. But on the other hand, he couldn't deny Izuku was cute. He had a very nice, squeezable looking body with a soft stomach.

He tilted his head wondering what Izuku's skin would feel like.

"Alright! Great job everyone!" Emi said as she clapped her hands together. "You guys did *wonderful*! I hope this sparked love in you all!"

Katsuki glanced to his right to see a couple move out of position and give each other a sloppy, wet kiss.

"I love you, sweetie," one woman said.

"I love you too," her partner said back. "I'm so happy to be here with you."

To Katsuki, those three little words were like a bucket of ice water being poured on his head.

He overheard a small chorus of 'I love yous', 'you did a great job sweetie' and 'I'm so proud of you'. Suddenly, everyone was looking at their significant other with such deep care and thoughtfulness that it caught him off guard.

Katsuki's stomach twisted when he watched Kirishima kiss Mina on the forehead. Then it tightened to the point his chest hurt when he saw Inasa playfully carry Shouto in his arms to the locker rooms.

Scarlet eyes glanced at the new ring on his finger.

Katsuki unceremoniously threw Izuku's legs off him, ignoring the small squeak from the man. Izuku rolled safely, expertly catching himself. Pissed off green eyes stared up at Katsuki in anger. But he didn't give a shit now.

He excused himself rapidly when he watched Momo and Jirou gaze lovingly at each other.

He quickly decided he needed to get air when his heart hummed low.

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki sat patiently on the bench in the men's locker room for Izuku.

He mulled over their chaotic morning and this stupid ass assignment. Several people trickled in from their aerobics class, but he didn't bother to say hello. He kept his head down and focused on his black sneakers. He could feel their concerned eyes crawling all over him as he listened to them chat about a bunch of mundane things.

He *hated* being in the midst of couples. It was one of his biggest pet peeves.

It felt taunting to watch all these extras live out the normal life he never got the option to experience.

He looked bitterly at the ring on his finger.

He really did think he could do a quick week here—kill Moore and then fucking leave. But, given his current predicament, he wasn't sure if he could stomach this assignment. Having to participate in all this crap was far different than stealth killing a mark.

When the room was empty, Izuku came barging in like a hurricane.

Green eyes glared around at the empty space before landing on him—and the anger in them grew exponentially.

"—*You*," Izuku hissed slowly. He marched up to Katsuki like he had gone crazy. "Another new rule: stop being such an asshole to *me*," Izuku threatened in a low tone. "I had Momo come up to me and ask if you were emotionally abusive after you left. Turns out, she's a therapist. She gave me her business card in case I, or maybe we, needed *therapy*."

Katsuki balked, not expecting that.

"Me? *Abusive*? Why the fuck would she think that?"

"Maybe—just *maybe*—she got the idea after you purposefully *dropped* me to the ground," Izuku said sarcastically. "These people don't know our history, but they *do* see how we

interact. So you better start treating me like I'm pumpkin pie or something or I swear I'm going to break your legs, leave you crippled in our room and do this assignment on my own."

"Okay, fine. Calm down," Katsuki said tiredly as he stood up. "I'll dial back on the cruelty."

He pressed his lips into a thin line in defeat because the little shit was right.

He didn't need anyone thinking he was fucking abusive and possibly get police involved. Aizawa would hop a flight and break his legs *himself* if he fumbled that badly.

"We're supposed to be affectionate," Izuku continued his lecture. "You know—*nicknames* and all that. You can't call me Dumbass, Deku, and Dipshit all day long in front of these people. If you like 'D' names that much, choose something else. Like dumpling—"

"—*Dumpling*?" Katsuki immediately imagined a bin full of dumplings with green little curls and freckles. He gagged. "Absolutely fucking not."

"Well, I don't care what you choose. Just stop insulting me in front of people when we're supposed to be madly in love! Call me something *nice*!" Izuku threw his hands up.

"Alright. How about my *darling* dumbass?" Katsuki sarcastically sneered.

"You could stand to drop the 'dumbass' in front of other people."

"Fine. I'll drop the dumbass." Katsuki scowled fully, his facial muscles unhappily straining with his frown. He leaned down into Izuku's space and held the blazing eye contact. "Does this do it for you, *darling*?"

It was meant to sound like a threat—but it didn't feel like one.

Izuku's annoyed demeanor shifted to flustered. Green eyes widened slightly as a rose-pink blush raced down to his neck. Katsuki's eyes followed the trail of it as it stopped at his clavicle—right where the Band-Aid was.

"Ye-Yeah," Izuku stammered. He cleared his throat and took a large step back to put space between them. "Darling works."

Katsuki hated to admit it—but 'darling' fit Izuku well.

Big doe eyes. Candy colored lips. Freckles. Soft looking skin. In another life, Katsuki would've claimed the man was a sweet, darling doll face if he didn't detest him so much.

They changed back into their normal clothing and re-strapped themselves with their weapons. When they emerged from the locker room, their group was standing there waiting for them. Momo and Jirou offered them strained smiles, obviously put off by the disaster of an aerobics class. Mina and Kirishima were too busy pushing their new workout plan on people. Inasa and Shouto seemed to be in their own little world while scrolling on their phones.

"Are you two okay?" Momo asked quietly. She eyed Katsuki particularly. "You two seemed like you had a rough time in there."

“A *really* rough time,” Jirou emphasized, cutting her eyes at Katsuki.

“We just have trouble with aerobics,” Izuku covered up. He gave a candy sweet smile and waved his hand. “But anyways, what’s next on the itinerary list? I’m super pumped to see the rest of the hotel activities.”

“After this we have some down time, then there’s open pool hours. Movie of our choice in the far side of the courtyard, or we could possibly go to…”

...Katsuki tuned her out listening to the long list.

There was fucking *more*.

Everything inside of him became disquieted. He looked at the clock and realized it was *barely* in the afternoon. He glanced around wearily at all the lovey dovey couples.

How the hell was he going to make it through this?

☽ ☽ ☽

The rest of the day was a disaster.

Not as bad as the aerobics class but still a disaster by Katsuki’s standards. It was awkward. Him and Izuku were awkward as hell together after everything they’ve been through. They both realized that this was going to be damn near impossible for them to get along. Katsuki tried his best and held hands with Izuku all day long in front of the other couples.

He even begrudgingly let the tiny man call him ‘sweetie’ and bit his tongue whenever he got the urge to call him a little shit.

That’s what couples did, right? Called each other stupid pet names and held each other’s hands?

Katsuki realized very quickly he had not a damn clue what couples did—or how they even acted.

However, Izuku seemed to. The freckled hitman covered up all his small blips. Every accidental insult that fell from Katsuki’s lips, Izuku corrected. When Katsuki was inadvertently rude to someone, Izuku smoothed it over with sweetness.

All the saccharine gestures made Katsuki nearly sour.

How the fuck was the bastard this good at faking it?

They didn’t have much luck running into Peter Moore again. Which was a damn bust. However, when they casually asked around it turned out the man barely spent time at the hotel. He came and checked in every morning and night during breakfast and dinner—but that was it.

Which meant he and Izuku had to hunt that bastard down off the premises.

By the time they got to the wine tasting part of the evening, Izuku seemed to be at his wits end with him. Katsuki didn't blame the little bastard. He was mildly surprised at his damn self. His behavior was way more irritable than normal.

He wanted to blame Izuku for it—but when another couple passed him by holding hands, Katsuki knew the real reason.

Katsuki decided to excuse himself to the lounge area under the ruse of being an introvert. Truthfully, he was more of an extrovert. However, with all the goddamn pink and love shit going around he felt his flight or fight kick in.

So, he separated from the group.

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki sat in the hotel lounge alone.

He was currently sitting in a stool at the bar counter. It was a decent sized space filled with mingling singles and couples relaxing. There were various activities such as pool, darts, and arcade games with shiny lights. The cheerfulness in the room was filled to the brim as an upbeat song played through the speakers above everyone's head.

Katsuki churned bitterly at how happy everyone seemed here.

He watched with numbed emotions as a guy in the corner approached a girl who had come in alone. They chatted for a bit before all the telltale signs of flirting kicked in.

"Hey, Taro," Moore's voice suddenly came up from beside him.

Katsuki perked up slightly in surprise, not expecting the man. He looked over his shoulder to see Peter Moore approaching him with a smile that could only be described as charismatic. Beside him was a slender man in an all-black suit.

The newcomer seemed around Peter Moore's age. He had long black hair with a hint of grey that was slicked back. His eyes were so deep that they nearly appeared blackish purple. There was a dark air about him that screamed 'I traffic humans' to Katsuki unlike Peter Moore, who seemed like a normal everyday man.

"Do you mind if we join you? We're waiting on a colleague to get back to us about an incoming shipment for the hotel," Moore asked with a hearty laugh.

"Sure, pull up a seat," Katsuki said. He gave a tight-lipped smile and gestured for them to join him.

"Perfect. Taro, please meet my lovely assistant, Minoru Koizumi," Moore started. He gestured happily to the man in all black beside him. "Koizumi, this is one of the two delightful husbands I was telling you about."

Koizumi didn't smile as he bowed slightly at the waist. "Pleasure to meet you, Taro."

“Pleasure is all mine,” Katsuki said automatically.

He quietly sized Koizumi up—wondering how much of a struggle he’d inevitably give later.

Moore ordered drinks for the three of them. Hard, dark whiskey that smelled fucking rich. The bartender smiled at him with trained politeness as he poured the liquid into the glass cup and slid it in front of him. Katsuki happily took it, ready to wash the day away with the help of some alcohol.

Moore toasted him with a friendly grin. His light brown eyes glanced around, searching for something. Or someone. Then a puzzled frown graced his slightly wrinkled face before he could drink some of the alcohol in his glass cup.

“Hm, wait a second.” Moore turned to him. “Taro? Where’s your Hiroji?”

“He’s out and about with the rest of our paradise crew,” Katsuki said as he took a swig of his whiskey. “I need some rest after such a long time. You know how that goes.”

“Ah. You’re an introvert?” Moore chuckled slightly. “My wife is the same way as you! She always prefers to be alone or stay inside some days.”

Katsuki didn’t miss the mild sarcastic eye roll from Koizumi, who folded his arms impatiently. Katsuki’s interests perked at the odd, contrasting demeanor of the two men in front of him.

They continued in conversation, Moore laying on his kingpin charm heavily. The man really did seem to enjoy him and Izuku’s presence. He kept saying how they reminded him of him and his wife. It nearly felt like a shame that Katsuki was deliberating which gun to end his life with. Key word: *nearly*. The charming bastard still kidnapped people and sold them in the underground.

While talking, Katsuki caught sight of matching golden pins on both Moore and Koizumi’s suit collars. It was in the shape of a dove carrying an olive branch. Katsuki’s eyes narrowed slightly, and he decided to turn up the charm.

Halfway through the night, Katsuki was sure he had the grimy bastard hooked. Moore was loving him. Then right as the man was belting out a hearty laugh, a bundle of deep green and pink entered his vision.

Izuku waved at him and Katsuki waved at him back, motioning for the dork to join them.

“Hey there, sweetie,” Izuku said as he slung his arm around him. Izuku gave a bright, sun-bright smile as he squeezed his shoulders. “I missed you!”

Katsuki paused lightly thinking about how to properly interact in front of their mark. What would a loving husband do after being away from their partner for a short while? Hug him? Kiss him? Pet him on the head and call him a good boy? He really didn’t fucking know.

Katsuki settled for wrapping his arm around Izuku’s waist. He pulled the smaller man in towards him tightly until they were nearly nose to nose.

“I missed you too.” Katsuki hesitated. “Darling.”

Izuku stared at him—surprised before quickly giving a semi-fake smile.

“Did you have some nice me-time, sweetie?” Izuku asked as he leaned in all the way and touched the tips of their noses.

The little bastard was selling the loving husband act for sure. Moore was grinning at them with an alcohol-flushed face like he was witnessing the world’s most adorable couple.

Katsuki nodded with a smirk. He resisted the urge to count the shades of green in Izuku’s eyes before motioning his head towards the two men in suits.

“I did, but I’m having an even better time talking with Mr. Sekai and his assistant here,” Katsuki said with a discreet emphasis on ‘assistant’.

“That’s great!” Izuku’s eyes lit up and it almost felt genuine. He wrapped his arms around Katsuki’s shoulders and turned to Koizumi with the nicest smile. “Please, allow me to introduce myself, I’m Bakugou Hiroji.”

“It’s nice to finally meet the other half of the pair Henry doesn’t seem to stop talking about.” Koizumi said in a curt manner.

The man didn’t smile too heavily once again and Katsuki concluded he behaved like a black cat. Quiet, judgmental, and standoffish. With every snobbish comment the man made, he unknowingly made it a lot easier for Katsuki to kill and frame him.

After another round of introductions, Katsuki let Izuku take the lead. He listened as Izuku conjured up fake stories about their lives that made them seem so utterly, disgustingly in love. He forced down a blush as Izuku leaned into him the entire time, his small hands brushing against his chest.

When the night began to end, Moore invited them out to drinks with him and Koizumi. Katsuki faked being thrilled about it. He preferred not to get chummy with people who he had to put in the ground—but it seemed like this assignment required a lot of it.

Both Moore and Koizumi said their goodbyes. Katsuki eyed the way they left out together. Something in the air was different between them outside of two colleagues. But he couldn’t quite place his finger on it.

When the two human traffickers were out of sight, Katsuki let his body slump and gently pushed Izuku away from him.

“I’m going to go fucking crazy within the next week,” Katsuki muttered. He threw back the rest of his whiskey, not minding the burning sensation in his throat. “This is more fucking acting than I anticipated. But at least we got an invitation for drinks. We can figure out where the man operates and lives...with some work.”

He grimaced, thinking about the possible future effort.

“Or we can look through his wallet for his ID that has his address,” Izuku said casually. He leaned against the bar counter and held up a white leather wallet.

Katsuki’s red eyes widened, not anticipating that.

Then again, he never could anticipate Izuku.

“You lifted his wallet? Fucking when?” Katsuki asked. He was mildly impressed and thankful because this made shit a lot easier.

“While you were discussing your favorite shows—which by the way I highly doubt yours is Candy or Not Candy,” Izuku said nonchalantly. “As much as I would love to keep chatting with the man, we’re liable to give him some reason to doubt we’re a couple if we get too friendly with him.”

“Agreed,” Katsuki said. “You’re good at all this fake bullshit, but I don’t know if I can keep it up if we gotta be all buddy-buddy with the man.”

“I also agree. I’m better at my job than you, so let’s try to get through with little slip ups as possible.”

Katsuki curled his upper lip in offense. “Better than *me*? Just because you can smile and call me *sweetie* doesn’t mean you’re better. You’re a terrible fucking shot.”

“And you have horrible self-awareness and acting skills,” Izuku shot back. Green eyes looked at him unimpressed. “You didn’t even notice I took your wallet too.”

Katsuki paused. He was about to berate Izuku—but looked at the green menace in disbelief. Without taking his eyes off Izuku, Katsuki patted his pants’ pockets. His heart dropped slightly when he realized his wallet was no longer on his body.

Izuku was slowly smiling at him in amusement.

“What the *fuck,* Deku—”

Izuku held up his black leather wallet with a charming smile. Katsuki gritted his teeth because he was so close to fucking punching this man. Screw trying to avoid the abusive husband image at this rate—the little shit was asking for it.

He shot his hand out to snatch his wallet and Izuku swiftly maneuvered it out of his reach. Katsuki quickly got out of his seat when Izuku started laughing and dodging his efforts to grab his wallet. They did a clumsy dance with Izuku being quicker than him and ducking every time Katsuki tried to take back his belongings.

“This isn’t fucking funny, give me my shit back—”

“—Let’s see what you have in your wallet, Taro,” Izuku said teasingly.

The tiny hands of the freckled hitman opened his leather wallet with lightning speed. However, when his eyes caught sight of what was inside—he froze.

Katsuki groaned at the invasion of privacy.

"...Durex XXL?" Izuku muttered. His freckled face went up in flames the longer he looked at the two blue squares sitting inside the folds. "Y-You have condoms in your wallet."

"Congratulations, you can use your big ass eyes," Katsuki spat sarcastically. He took advantage of the moment of Izuku's stillness to snatch his wallet back. He put it back in his pants pocket and secured it tightly. "Don't fucking pick pocket me again. I'll stab you next time you lay a finger on my shit."

"Why do you have condoms on an assignment?" Izuku asked in a quiet whisper.

Katsuki stared at Izuku as if he was stupid.

"Isn't it obvious? Look around—this place is a fuck fest disguised in pastels," Katsuki said dryly. He jotted his chin to the pair off in the back corner, who were making out rather heavily. Izuku looked at them too and the blush on his face deepened. "Those two didn't come in here together but look at them now—ready to go fuck like animals probably. I thought I was going to get laid while I was here."

"I-I guess," Izuku stuttered out. He wearily eyed the pair who were getting friskier by the second. "B-But isn't that compromising the assignment to have sex with people? You're creating unnecessary loose ends."

"Fucking is fucking at the end of the day," Katsuki said without much real thought. He shrugged. "I need stress relief like any normal human. Thankfully, I'm handsome so I get lucky a lot on assignments if there's room for it."

Izuku swallowed. His eyes looked to the ground shyly.

"Are you still hoping to get lucky on this assignment?"

Katsuki barked out a dry laugh. "Naw. I think I can count this as a dry mission considering the little green cock block that's plastered to me."

"Little green cock block?" Izuku scrunched his face and stared at him. "You mean the wedding band?"

"No, Deku. I fucking mean *you*."

Izuku frowned deeply. "I take offense to that type of description."

"Good." Katsuki smirked playfully at the stupid little pout on Izuku's pink lips. "No one else is around. I can be an asshole if I want. Now open that bastard's wallet and let's see what we got. He'll probably realize it's missing soon."

Izuku huffed unhappily before shaking his head. He picked up the sleek white leather wallet and clicked open the golden lock. He opened the wallet but they both were surprised not to find anything worthwhile inside.

There was no money. No ID and no real information.

Katsuki frowned deeply because he was only partially surprised. Of course, a kingpin human trafficker wouldn't carry around his address or personal information. But what was the strangest thing was that the wallet was still full.

In all the slots were high quality all black cards.

"It's...business cards?" Izuku said and reached in to grab one. He flipped over the black card to be met with nothing but the icon of a singular white dove. "But they have no address or information on it?"

"It has this white dove on it," Katsuki mumbled as he pointed to the icon. "That bastard and his assistant had golden dove pins on the collar of their suits earlier too."

The two hitmen cut their eyes to each other at the same time.

White doves. The White Dove.

"Well, it looks like we'll be going on that cruise boat after all," Izuku said seriously. "I'll buy tickets for us to go on it tomorrow."

Katsuki nodded. Something about this felt off. There was a small prickle of ominous warning that crawled all over his skin. He only ever got this type of sensation when he felt like there was going to be more complications than usual for an assignment.

He frowned deeply the longer he looked at the white dove on the card.

☽ ☽ ☽

When they finally made their way back to the room, Katsuki groaned loudly in joy.

He threw his sunglasses on the table and tiredly raked his hands through his hair. Izuku didn't say much to him, the awkwardness from the day still dripped heavily on them. He could sense Izuku was unimpressed at his subpar performance as a perfectly loving husband.

They both changed into their night clothes without too much of a word to each other. Izuku silently bought the cruise tickets for tomorrow morning.

"The White Dove is a love-cruise boat," Izuku said briefly without looking at him. "It transports people to and from Ie Island, Okinawa. It's a four-hour trip there. Meaning, it'll be an eight hour round trip. That'll be our full day tomorrow."

When Katsuki took his place on the tiny ass couch, he was already dreading the next day.

Katsuki pulled the blanket over himself but paused when he caught sight of the pile of Izuku's luggage off in the corner.

He hadn't really *looked* before. He had been too caught up in the denial of being stuck in Pink-goo-goo-eyed Land with his designated life menace.

But when he did stare, he saw Izuku plop his yellow backpack on top of a black violin case.

Katsuki blinked hard—trying to convince himself that this wasn't one of his reality-distorted dreams. He looked back and forth between Izuku and the violin case.

"Is that, uh, yours?" Katsuki asked before he could stop himself.

"Mhm." Izuku hummed in agreement without looking at him. "I play violin sometimes. I like to bring it with me during assignments. If I have down time I practice."

"Really?" Katsuki said. He felt a slight sense of déjà vu. "I know you said you liked listening to violin music, but you didn't mention that you played."

"I like to do both. Play and listen."

"But why the violin?"

He didn't understand why, but the longer he stared at Izuku's instrument's case the more he felt a forgotten piece of his memory struggling towards the surface.

"I fell in love with it when I was a kid," Izuku answered honestly. "I used to listen to violin music all the time back then." Izuku finally peered over to him. There was a hint of cautious curiosity lying at the bottom of that sea of green. "Do...Do you like classical music by any chance?"

"I actually love it," Katsuki admitted before he could catch himself. He was surprised a bit to see how Izuku and him shared a very specific interest. His own cautious curiosity took the wheel as well. "I memorized a lot of the classics. It's, uh, a small hobby of mine on the side. Do you play classical music or more modern music?"

"Both," Izuku admitted with a tiny smile. "I'm not that good though, I'm self taught. So don't get your hopes up if you're thinking I can play for you one day."

"Phfft." Katsuki clicked his tongue and shook his head. "I wouldn't dream of it."

Izuku seemed a tiny bit less annoyed and offered him a small smile.

The conversation didn't continue. Izuku turned off the lights and climbed under the covers, signaling for Katsuki to go to bed as well. But he wanted to ask more questions about Izuku —suddenly curious after seeing the violin. He reasoned it was for the mission. He had to get to know Izuku solely to play the part as his husband, right? He didn't truly give a damn about the little pain in the ass.

But there was a small budding sensation of disappointment in his chest when Izuku rolled over.

Katsuki took the hint and tried to close his eyes. He did his best to get comfortable on the tiny grey couch, but it was hard. His limbs awkwardly hung off the arms and he was way too big to fit correctly.

“You can get in the bed,” Izuku’s shy voice said in the dark. “That couch is bad for your back.”

Katsuki cut his eyes to the other hitman, thinking he had to be joking. But Izuku wasn’t. Katsuki watched as the smaller man shifted over in the heart shaped bed. There was a large openness waiting for him in the red silky sheets and it was admittedly tempting.

“No,” Katsuki rejected immediately. “I’ll be fine. I’m not sleeping in the same bed with you. You might try to smother me in my sleep.”

“I won’t.” Izuku sighed and waved him over again. “I already told you: if I wanted to kill you, I would’ve done it by now.”

Katsuki shook his head.

“Really. Get in the bed. I need you at your best—not with a potential crick in your neck,” Izuku pressed. “We can resume like normal after this assignment, but I prefer to do this without getting a chiropractor involved.”

Katsuki was going to flat out reject it. He was going to tell Izuku to go to hell and mind his own business—but when he tried to shift again on the couch, his neck muscles screamed at him in pain.

Katsuki sat up all the way in defeat. “Fine.”

He gathered all the pillows he could in his hand with a deep scowl.

“I’m going to make a barrier between us,” Katsuki announced, dead serious. “If you cross it —I will kill you.”

It was almost comical. As if a small row of fucking feather filled *pillows* could stop Izuku from killing him if he wanted. But to hell with it, it made him feel better and somewhat safer. At least this way they wouldn’t accidentally wake up cuddling or some shit. Katsuki’s stomach nearly hurled at the thought.

He carefully stacked the extra red pillows straight down the center of the heart shape. Izuku’s big ass eyes watched the whole time, an unreadable emotion glazed them over. When Katsuki laid down and got under the covers, he couldn’t see Izuku. However, he could sense the other man lying still on the other side.

A strange quietness blanketed them both in the dark under the clicking fan.

“You’re not very good at pretending to be in love,” Izuku murmured and finally broke the silence.

“It’s hard to mimic an emotion you’ve never felt before,” Katsuki grumbled. He shifted against the silky pillow and huffed through his nose. “So, excuse the hell out of me for not fitting the role perfectly.”

“You’ve never been in love? Not once?”

Katsuki shook his head. “No. I’m not the type to fall in love. But you seem like it though.”

“What makes you say that?”

“You have the doting husband act down like an expert,” Katsuki said bitterly. “You probably fall in love over and over again until your bleeding heart is black and blue.”

“I-I’ve never been in love either—or at least I don’t think I have.”

Katsuki frowned in surprise.

He lifted himself up with his arms to peer over the pillow barrier. Izuku was laying down, staring up at the ceiling. His green eyes were looking off in the distance like he was in a long-lost memory and there was a tiny blush rising along the bridge of his button nose.

“Really?” Katsuki said in disbelief. “There’s no fucking way. You have to have had *one* relationship.”

“Nope. Never even dated anyone. You?”

“No. I’ve never had a relationship either.”

Izuku finally turned to him, and they made eye contact. But this time neither looked away.

A new feeling of vulnerability settled between them.

Katsuki mulled over how Izuku was more like him than he thought. Almost enharmonic, like a music note with a different name that sounded the same.

Sure, some people in their field dated. Sometimes they dated only as a disguise to appear normal. Sometimes others dated within colleagues, which usually ended in violent breakups. But in most cases, hitmen kept their vanilla partners in the dark.

“Like you said this morning: love, it’s—it’s not for people like us.” Izuku gave him a sad smile. For some reason, hearing that he was right didn’t make Katsuki happy. “I’m only mimicking what I’ve read in books.”

Scarlet eyes studied Izuku a little longer than they needed to.

Katsuki took in all the freckles, the small indentations of dimples on Izuku’s full cheeks and the underlying sadness in his deep green eyes. He thought about the worn-down romance novel sitting on Izuku’s side of the bed in a new light.

“But you like reading about love?”

“I do.” Izuku gave a small laugh, as if what he was saying was ridiculous. “It’s nice to gaze into a window about what it might be like.”

“What made you start liking that type of stuff?” Katsuki didn’t know why he asked as his curiosity bloomed.

“Ah, well, I started getting into the romance genre as a kid because it’s always so happy and pleasant. It fills you up with such a warm feeling that you feel like your heart is about to burst at the seams.”

“I guess I never understood the appeal of it,” Katsuki admitted. “All that soft, gooey eyed bullshit doesn’t do anything for me.”

He dropped his guard for a split second—thinking about all his friends who had romantic partners. He never could imagine himself in their place, feeling as though he would be like a sinner in church to participate in such a thing. Someone with a bloody body count like his being hopelessly in love didn’t seem right.

Besides, who would love someone like him anyways?

“Love isn’t always soft,” Izuku whispered. He shifted his body to roll over towards Katsuki fully, the silky sheets spilling down his body. “It can be gentle like tender lips against your nape. Or it can be deadly like sharp claws tearing into your throat. There isn’t one type of love.”

Katsuki thought about that as he looked at Izuku’s thick, dark eye lashes.

“Well, I wouldn’t know what either feels like—soft love or deadly love.”

“...Me either, I guess.”

There was a long silence as they held eye contact.

Katsuki’s heart did that weird flip again.

Izuku sucked in his lips and turned his eyes away eventually when his face started to turn pink. Katsuki wondered what the other man was thinking about for his face to flush that deep.

“Y’know,” Izuku started. He didn’t look back towards Katsuki. “If you’re going to have trouble pretending to be my husband, this means we’re going to have a tough time convincing Moore we’re in love. Which is going to cause issues for us to gain his trust. Our plan is only going to work if we’re in harmony.”

Katsuki grimaced because Izuku was right.

They had already caused a commotion during that stupid ass aerobics class because they couldn’t get along for an *hour*. He winced thinking about Momo walking up to Izuku asking him if he was abusive towards him or not—it wasn’t a good look. Surely Peter Moore didn’t want to associate with them if he knew they were possibly just drama walking.

Katsuki decided at that moment to swallow his pride and put the assignment first.

“Teach me,” he said hushly.

For a moment, there was nothing but silence.

Izuku stared at him, baffled, and tilted his head in a way that was nearly cute.

Katsuki struggled to maintain eye contact with those big, deceivingly innocent doe eyes when his heart did a flip again.

“Er, for this assignment,” Katsuki elaborated. He looked up at the spinning ceiling fan, wondering if he was going to regret this. “You clearly know how to mimic all this lovey dovey bullshit to the last bat of an eyelash. So, show me how to play the dumb part of a doting husband until we finish off that bastard.”

“Are you sure, Katsuki?”

Hearing his name spoken by the other hitman for the first time only solidified his decision.

“Yeah. Teach me how to be in love, Izuku.”

Chapter End Notes

I hope you enjoyed it! Please let me know what you think below. Especially for this story I am eager for feedback, comments, theories and screams :’) 🧡💚 Also feel free to comment in your native language if you’re more comfortable with it! I don’t mind at all ^.^ Thanks so much for reading!!

Chapter 4: Lento

Chapter Summary

> Katsuki gets his first lesson in pretending to be in love, and an unexpected turn happens on their assignment.

Chapter Notes

> Hello! Welcome back. This chapter is really indulgent. I'm really enjoying the dynamic set up in his fic and I will probably wind up writing long chapter due to just how fun it is. Please give the songs a listen too! Thank you so much :)
>
> **The fic was beta'd by the moon of my life, LunaToons on AO3**

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 4 - Lento

.

.

.

“Yeah. Teach me how to be in love, Izuku.”

Izuku stared at him for a long moment.

Endless green eyes searched his eyes and face for any hint of hesitation, but there was none. Katsuki meant it in full earnest. He maintained eye contact with Izuku so that the other would know he was serious. When that delicate, candy colored blush sprinkled across Izuku’s freckles, Katsuki could feel a shift between them.

“Okay,” Izuku said back in the softest voice he ever used before. “I can teach you what I know. We can start tomorrow.”

Katsuki nodded while Izuku gave him a timid smile.

They said goodnight with a different aura settled around the pastel-colored room. The last thing Katsuki saw before he closed his eyes was Izuku’s violin. The sleek black case tugged

at something in his mind as closed his eyes. He decided not to dwell on it, but it seemed like his subconscious had other plans.

A sinking feeling enveloped him, but he let himself be tugged under. He drifted off quietly without a word.

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki was dreaming again.

That night when he closed his eyes, the same sequence occurred: he fell into the darkness. However, this time he wasn't afraid. He was curious as to what was beneath the surface.

He let the darkness slither into his mind as he focused on his distorted childhood memories. The gentle melody of violins reached his ears as he was once again thrusted into his seven-year-old self. He looked around carefully, the winter scene appearing exactly the way it was before. Neither the statue of the angel or the forgotten water fountain was crumbling. They were normal just like they had been before.

His vignetted vision focused on the elderly man who had snow white hair and a pure ivory violin. He was playing his sad song again, moving his body with a type of despair Katsuki would come to understand later in life. But for now, he was curious as to what the name of the song was. The tempo was faster in this dream than it was in the previous one, but still slow and deep.

"Are you cold?"

Katsuki froze. He turned his head slowly to the tiny voice.

Staring back at him was the blurry faced boy. This time the details of his hair were slightly clearer. He had a bundle of dark curls that nearly appeared black under the light of the winter night. That one eye of his was still wrapped with a white bandage that had dried blood splattered on it.

"Are you cold?" He repeated.

A small shiver ran up his spine from the chilly air.

"Ye-Yeah," he answered as if he had said it before.

The blurry faced boy quickly stood up. He couldn't see his face, but even in his dreams he remembered there being concern etched in deeply. The no-faced boy stripped himself of his red coat and winter gear, handing it over to Katsuki.

At first, Katsuki shook his head and rejected it. What was this kid doing? He was going to be freezing—but the no-faced boy ignored his protests.

Tiny hands placed the warm jacket on his shoulders and forcefully pushed his hands through the arms of the coat. Katsuki wanted to say no, but the lingering body heat inside of the coat made his bones hum happily. He held back tears as the nameless child gave him his winter

clothes. Earmuffs. Gloves. Scarf. Jacket. All things he once wished his mother bought for him before she left. When he was fully zipped up tight, the tiny blurry boy led him to the wooden bench.

The sound of violin continued as Katsuki's tattered shoes were replaced with boots that were slightly too tight.

There was a blurry smile.

"There you go!" The boy said happily. He sat down on the bench too, tiny legs dangling. "You're all warm now."

Katsuki noticed the tiny lisp on his words as he spoke a beat too quickly. The mysterious boy had sat there in nothing but his jeans and a dark green sweater. His white socks had soaked up some of the wet snow, but it seemed like he didn't care. He only cared about keeping Katsuki warm.

"What about you?" Katsuki asked. The wind blew harshly but this time, Katsuki didn't feel the cut of it. He was thankful but there was a twinge of guilt in his chest. "You're going to be cold now."

"I can get another coat and stuff," the boy replied easily. He tilted his head at Katsuki. "Where're your parents?"

"They're..." He halted.

He looked at the blurry face of the other boy, struggling to clear the fog around what he looked like. He thought about his parents and how his mother said she'd be right back. But then he thought about his dad, who was dead. Katsuki swallowed in shame.

"Th-They're not here. My mom said she would be right back. B-But it's been a month."

He couldn't help the quivering in his voice. What if his mom had died too?

"She left you?" The blurry faced boy asked. "What about you dad?"

"I'm—" Katsuki blinked back tears. It was put so bluntly that he had to face the facts straight on. He was abandoned. Fucking abandoned. The emotions in the dream felt real. "—I'm alone."

"Do you have food?"

Katsuki shook his head.

"Are you hungry?"

Katsuki nodded his head.

"Do you have a place to stay?"

Katsuki shook his head again.

But then he thought about it. Technically, he did? He glanced cautiously at the other boy before deciding he could trust him. Katsuki lifted his gloved hand and pointed around the corner to the alley. The blurry faced boy followed the gesture, looking towards the row of makeshift houses and tents.

The other kid seemed to disapprove when he grew quiet.

When there was no response, Katsuki's throat welled up in embarrassment. It strangled him like invisible hands around his neck as he thought about all he didn't have.

Most kids his age had parents who loved them. Fed them. Bought them proper clothes. Made sure they were in school. Despite it not being *his* fault, Katsuki was somewhat ashamed. He knew people viewed the apple that fell from the broken tree equally as faulty.

He looked down at the new clothes that had been bestowed upon him bitterly. This kid clearly had someone who loved him. It made Katsuki nearly green with envy. Why wasn't he as lucky to have normal parents like this kid? Was there something wrong with him?

Was he *that* unlovable?

Then the other kid perked up and jumped down off the bench.

Even though Katsuki couldn't see his face in his dream, he could remember the feeling of his heart skipping a tiny beat. He was given a caring smile from the boy as the violinist in the background repeated his song once more. It was always the same captivating yet eerie melody.

"I'll get you s'food!" The smaller boy spun around quickly to leave.

"Wait, take your boots," Katsuki called out.

The other small child stopped and nodded in agreement. They shuffled around with the boots once more, and Katsuki tucked his cold feet under his pants' legs.

"You stay right here, please. I'll be right back!"

And he did. It wasn't as if he had anywhere else to go.

Katsuki sat on that snow covered bench studying the violinist, who was in his own world. The violinist was peculiar. He mumbled to himself different words Katsuki didn't know yet like crescendo, decrescendo and lento.

Other foreign sounding words came toppling out as Katsuki waited for the nameless boy to return.

An inkling of fear inside of Katsuki told him that the other boy wasn't coming back. His distorted subconscious reminded him he was unlovable and that no one *really* cared for him. His own mother couldn't—so why the hell would anyone else? Especially some rich kid. He

should just leave. He should continue searching for his mother in this winter storm. But instead, he stayed rooted on the bench.

He made eye contact with the homeless violinist who smiled woefully at him.

Within the hour, shuffling back was the boy with the bloodied bandage. Katsuki's lonely heart filled with a tiny bit of hope. He felt more thankful than ever when the smaller boy held up a tiny plastic bag full of junk food. Katsuki briefly wondered where he got it from but didn't ask any questions as he started to munch down on a bag of chips.

"Thank you," Katsuki whispered. "You didn't have to do this for me."

"S'okay. You were cold. I can get more stuffs for you too!" The sweet voice said to him. "What's your name?"

He remembered how he thought this boy was sweet. The sweetest person he had ever known. Katsuki stared at the blurry faced boy, wishing his dream was clearer.

"My name is Katsuki."

"Kah-sue-key," the other boy repeated slowly, butchering the pronunciation of his name.

Katsuki pursed his lips and shook his head. He repeated his name once more, but slowly. The other boy, who had a tiny lisp, tried to say the syllables with him but failed every time. It was nearly amusing for young Katsuki to watch the other boy stumble until he was pink in the face.

"Ah...'m sorry," the mystery boy said sadly. He looked down shamefully. "I don't think I can say it right."

Katsuki shrugged, not truly caring. He was more thankful for the clothes and food. "It's alright, don't sweat it. You can call me something else."

Then, a tiny hand reached out and grabbed his.

Warm. That was Katsuki's first thought as his little heart did a peculiar flip.

"Can I call you Kacchan?" The blurry faced boy asked.

Katsuki's heart did another flip as he squeezed the hand in his.

"Ye-Yeah," he replied. He wasn't sure if he stammered from the cold or the warm feeling inside of his chest. "Kacchan works. What's your name?"

The boy smiled through the fog surrounding him and answered eagerly.

But there was nothing but static noise.

Katsuki frowned as strained to hear. He repeated his question, but the same thing occurred. He tried to say something again, but this time his throat clammed up without warning.

He stared ahead, confused as he touched his neck. He attempted to swallow the sudden lump in his throat, but it didn't budge. It started to grow larger, obstructing his windpipe. The fear inside of him clawed into his sternum unnervingly. He shook violently to his core because the sensation was frightening. It continued until it felt like multiple sets of snake fangs were sinking into his throat. Katsuki tried to scream but *couldn't*.

He tried to ask for his name again.

He wanted to know the sweet boy's name so badly. But the words never formed on his tongue as the invisible snake fangs sunk deeper. He held on tighter to the boy's hand as he slipped away. They grew further apart until their interlocked fingers slipped out of each other's hold.

No. No no no no—

He reached back out desperately for the boy who reached back for him. Katsuki's mind was desperately trying to stay within his dream-memory. He wanted to stay and remember the blurry faced boy's name so damn much. He begged for some alleviation on his airway and for the dream to continue.

However, none of his wishes came true.

The blurry face of the other child became blurrier as the edges of his vision began to blacken. His sight blackened until all he could see was the dark, endless abyss. He stayed there in the darkness for an inconceivable amount of time. Floating in nothing until he could feel his eyes slowly blink open. With each gradual blink, more light came to.

But when his vision returned, Katsuki was staring up at the spinning ceiling fan in the hotel room.

He was awake.

His heart hummed low and heavy in disappointment. Of course, he *had* to wake up right before he could remember that damn boy's name. It was irony in its finest form, and it was thick in the air.

Katsuki laid there. His chest felt heavy like bricks were being laid on top.

The morning silence blanketed him as he stared up blankly at the ceiling for a long time. He listened to the clicking of the turning fan in the dawn-colored room pensively. The sleep in his mind was still heavy like a thousand stones weighing him down. He searched his brain for the elusive name, but he found nothing after several long minutes.

Katsuki lifted his hands up to his face as he remembered how warm the other boy's hand was. His sullen scarlet eyes traced all the callouses and lines on his hands in the sunlight. Invisible blood stains from over the years were visible to his eyes, caked on with underlying guilt. He foolishly wondered if that same boy would be mortified to know he helped save someone who turned out to be a hitman.

Katsuki sighed bitterly and dropped his hands.

Katsuki leaned up slowly in the bed by his forearms as his tired eyes looked around the pink and red room. His back was feeling immensely better than when he had slept on the couch. He was never going to directly thank Izuku for the suggestion, but he did so privately as he rolled his neck.

Speaking of the menace.

Katsuki turned and glanced over the makeshift pillow barrier to see Izuku sleeping soundly. He was cuddled into the side of the pillow barrier, tightly hugging a pillow with his arms and legs. A light snore slipped past his lips and his green curls were a mess. The deep green contrast against the red silk was an interesting sight for Katsuki. He found himself studying the way the gentle morning light caressed Izuku's skin.

He looks innocent. Katsuki thought as he was looking at Izuku in his oversized pajamas. He tilted his head, conflicting emotions swarmed his chest and stung him like a nest of wasps. *How the hell does someone as lethal as him look so innocent when he fucking sleeps?*

Katsuki felt the irritation prickling against his core, but then Izuku shifted slightly, and a part of his bang fell over his eye.

Katsuki's heart skipped a beat as a subtle sense of déjà vu cradled him.

He leaned in close, over the pillow barrier, to get a better look. He didn't know why his curiosity was burning deep in him suddenly—but it threatened to consume him if he didn't move in. He felt compelled by an invisible string attached to his heart towards the sleeping man.

He stared extremely hard at Izuku's sleeping face and the way his bang covered up his eye.

He squinted his eyes to study Izuku's freckles closely.

An image of the blurry faced boy's bandaged eye appeared in his mind. Then the unclear memory overlapped with the vision of Izuku sleeping.

"Ah, *Katsuki*." Izuku's groggy voice drew out his name. The breathlessness in his tone made red eyes widen by several fractions. He froze on the spot as Izuku stirred and opened his eyes. Deep green eyes glanced up towards him. "Is watching people while they sleep a pastime of yours?"

Katsuki blinked rapidly.

"You're fucking *awake*?" He blushed deep red in embarrassment and leaned away from Izuku.

"I just woke up," Izuku said tiredly. He snuggled back into his pillow and closed his eyes. "But please, don't stop on my account. If this is part of your morning routine, continue on being a pervert."

Katsuki's eyebrow twitched as he watched Izuku peacefully go back to sleep.

This...little...shit.

Katsuki thwacked Izuku with the nearest pillow he could reach. Izuku yelled out a protest, putting his hands up in defense. Katsuki gave several more spite-filled swings.

“I’m—” Swing. “Not—” Swing. “A—” Swing. “—Fucking *pervert*, you *eye sore*!”

“I’m not judging you! There’s worse things in life than being a closeted creeper!”

Izuku blocked the next several incoming swings until he caught the pillow midair with a sheepish smile. He tugged it close and Katsuki yelped in surprise as he got tugged over the flimsy barrier with the pillow by Izuku’s strength. Katsuki’s red eyes widened at the now close face-to-face proximity.

“I have to say, I didn’t peg you as the type to watch someone while they sleep.” Izuku said seriously. “But it makes sense when I think about it.”

Katsuki groaned in frustration and pushed himself *far* away from the damn Deku.

“I hate you,” Katsuki hissed. “I fucking hate you.”

Fucking forget it.

He cursed that annoying fucking dream of the blurry faced boy and how silly he felt for oddly making the connection with Izuku’s bang. To hell with it. He was going to drive himself crazy at this rate thinking about that year of his life. He made himself, *once again*, promise to bury the memory that seemed to be banging on the surface.

He threw another pillow at Izuku for good measure.

☽ ☽ ☽

They got ready for that god forsaken love boat without any other odd occurrences.

Katsuki was mentally cursing himself when Izuku genuinely asked if he was watching him sleep. The cautious stare from those deep green eyes made Katsuki realize, yeah, he was kind of being a weirdo. Given their history, he didn’t blame Izuku for seeming slightly on edge. But Katsuki backtracked his actions with a dumb excuse of a fly being on Izuku’s nose since he couldn’t give an honest answer.

Because how did one say: “I wasn’t watching you sleep like some creep. I’ve been having these weird dreams about the year my mother abandoned me. In that moment, with your bangs over your eye, you reminded me of the kid who took care of me. He, uh, had a bloody bandage over one of his eyes—”

Just thinking about possibly saying that out loud made Katsuki cringe.

They got dressed quickly, Izuku taking the liberty to dress in the bathroom. Probably because he was aware of Katsuki staring at his ass yesterday in the locker room.

The blond hitman picked out a long sleeve v-neck black shirt today. He matched it with his knee-high black shorts and strapped himself with his guns and knife accordingly. When Izuku emerged from the bathroom in his tacky pastels, Katsuki ignored all comments about 'it's going to be scorching today' from the short stack. He slid on his usual silver chain and black fang earrings in his ear.

But as they made their way to the downtown area of Nago, Katsuki once again found out Izuku was fucking right.

The August sun was unforgiving as it blazed down on them in the excruciatingly long line for The White Love. He detested admitting it, but the little shit had been right. He shouldn't have worn all black again—but he'd be damned if he dressed in ugly pastels like the other hitman.

Katsuki grumbled unhappily as he fanned himself with the tiny pamphlet that read 'White Dove Love Boat.' The title was in a classy golden font and tiny images of doves on it were littered throughout. He glanced through the itinerary for the love boat and saw all the little activities.

Cooking classes. Movies. Sunbathing. Romantic seaside dinner.

His stomach churned and he tried his best not to hurl on Izuku.

But, speaking of—he cut his eyes to the man next to him who was leaning over the railing of the wooden dock.

His faux husband was appreciating the view with a tranquil aura surrounding him. Izuku's head was tilted back, enjoying the early sea breeze in his silky curls. His bright green eyes were sparkling in the same way as the blue ocean under the sun.

He was dressed in a cutesy pink button-down shirt that had a black bow at the neck. It was tucked into his jean shorts and sneakers. Today his calf-high socks, that were hiding his knives, matched the same color of his shirt. To top it off, he was wearing his big ass floppy straw sun hat that was decorated in pink flowers and big ass black bow. And those stupid little heart shaped glasses. The smile pinned on Izuku's pink lips was blissful and in his hands was that romance novel.

Katsuki studied Izuku's side profile for a while against the background of the oceanside landscape. Then he shook himself out of it when he realized he was—*yet again*—staring.

He turned his sights on the boat itself. It was absolutely fucking huge. Katsuki counted the floors, and it was easily a triple decker—possibly four but he couldn't see from where they were in line. He could hear a soft melody coming from the top of the boat in the distance. It mixed with the sound of giggles and laughter in the air.

"This boat better be the most relaxing fucking cruise in the world to have us out here in the sun this long," Katsuki grumbled as the line finally started to move. He watched impatiently as all the people started to board, getting their tickets punched one by one.

“I told you not to wear all black again,” Izuku chuckled at him. “You’re basically asking to get cooked alive in that.”

“My wardrobe is one-hundred percent black, Deku,” Katsuki quipped back. “I have nothing else to wear and even if I had the choice, I would still choose black.”

Izuku tilted his head at him, looking at his fang shaped earrings. “Why don’t you like wearing colors?”

“Why do you? Especially ugly pastels like that—” Katsuki gestured up and down to Izuku’s cute—er, not cute. Ugly. Izuku’s really fucking ugly outfit. “You look repulsive. You stand out too much.”

“Uh, this isn’t what I usually wear,” Izuku admitted. His cheeks dusted with a light pink shade as he looked down to their feet. “This is what I packed for this assignment. I figured it would be a good cover to blend in—plus, I always wanted to wear something bright like this for once.”

“You really are treating this like a goddamn vacation,” Katsuki grumbled in disbelief.

Izuku gave him a soft smile. “I’m just enjoying being in a really nice place like this.”

Katsuki nearly snorted at the irony. Nice place. Yeah right. These fuckers kidnapped people and covered up the missing’s person reports.

“Hey. You’re not going to push me overboard, are you?” Izuku asked, half seriously and half playfully.

“I wouldn’t be stupid enough to do that with people around.”

Izuku raised a brow at him. “So, you’d do it when people aren’t around?”

“I guess you’ll just have to wait and see, huh.”

Izuku glared at him, and his stupid little fingers clutched the book angrily. Katsuki grinned like the devil as they finally made their way to the front of the line and the employee bunched their white dove shaped tickets with a captivating smile.

“Enjoy your time on the White Dove!” She said, flashing her pearly white teeth. “There’s no other love boat around to make paradise seem more perfect!”

Izuku mirrored the friendliness while Katsuki scowled. He snatched both of their tickets out of her hand, not for one second buying into the overt kindness. Her brown eyes bulged at the sudden aggression and Izuku lightly hit his arm. Izuku quickly mumbled apologized and quickly hooked onto his arm to drag him away.

“*Taro*,” his faux husband hissed. Blazing green eyes shot him a disapproving stare as they walked up the ramp to the deck together. “Why would you do that?”

“She was over-selling the romantic bullshit. It was annoying.”

“Your first lesson on how to be in love starts now,” Izuku said. The arm hooked onto his tightened to the point Katsuki felt the unspoken threat. “People who are in love are *happy*. And happy people are relaxed. Therefore, they *aren’t* unnecessarily rude to someone who is just doing their job.”

“I think being rude to her was quite necessary. Some people need their stupid romantic bubble popped.”

“You really hate this stuff. Don’t you?”

“Yup. With every fiber of my goddamn existence.”

Izuku sighed helplessly. He shook his head lightly as they made their way to the boat’s deck. Both of their eyes widened by a small fraction as they took in the sight.

In contrast to the pink painted hotel, The White Dove was much like the dining area. Classy with soft colors of white, cream, and gold trimmings. The deck was mahogany and dipping down from the top deck to the bottom were bright romantic white fairy lights. Waiters dressed in all white beach casual clothes were serving food and drinks and giving out bright smiles.

The deck was full of plush, long beach chairs that were paired off in twos. Above each pair was a large white umbrella to protect from the beating sun. Off to the side on the deck was a small band with various instruments playing an upbeat tune.

Izuku’s eyes lit up as he saw that in front of the band there was enough desk room for some couples to dance joyfully together. Katsuki’s eyes glared as he watched two people make out on the railing.

“For fucks’ sake. This is—”

“—Nice!” Izuku finished happily. Immediately the short stack started to drag Katsuki by his arm off to the deck. “Hurry! Let’s stake our claim on one of the chairs next to the band.”

Katsuki let himself be pulled along without saying too much as he watched the excitement in Izuku triple. He wanted to be annoyed. Really, he did. But the longer he carefully studied the other man in that moment, he witnessed seeing an emotion he hadn’t seen yet.

Izuku was genuinely happy.

He had seen many emotions spark across Izuku’s delicate freckled features: Resentment. Spite. Annoyance. Regret. Homicide. Conflict. Katsuki had even seen an emotion border lining hate, but it was never quite fiery enough to reach all the way. But he had not once seen Izuku truly joyful.

The radiant expression on his delicate features was jarring. It was a true juxtaposition to what he was used to and made Katsuki swallow all the snarky comments he was about to make. The small seed of his curiosity for Izuku beckoned to be watered as he looked at the shimmering lights reflected in deep green irises.

They sat down at the chairs that were close to the band and the front of the boat. Izuku plopped down, book in hand, with a curious gaze. His head was upright like a small fox that was gazing around happily. Katsuki sat down next to him and immediately pulled his sunglasses from the top of his head over his eyes.

“Well, we have four hours to kill,” Katsuki mumbled. He leaned back and crossed his legs. “What should we do until then, dork?”

Izuku grinned at him happily and held up his book. Katsuki disliked the way he saw actual notes in the neon-colored tabs.

“I was hoping we could begin your lessons on how to fake being in love! I already have a lesson plan for you.”

“A lesson *plan*?” Katsuki scoffed and muttered under his breath to himself, “you really are a little fucking nerd.”

Izuku narrowed his eyes at him and leaned in. “What did you say?”

“Nothing,” Katsuki quickly backtracked. Izuku’s eyes narrowed when the blond smirked arrogantly at him. “Now what is in this lesson plan of yours, Deku?”

Izuku huffed before opening to some pages of the book. They were marked up and down with notes, highlights, and neon-colored tabs. “I tabbed some pages in this book that I want to have you look at and we can take it one step at a time. We’ll begin at the basics.”

Katsuki scowled. “There are basics to pretending to be in love?”

“Yes. Affection and intimacy being two big ones.”

“I have no issue being intimate with someone,” Katsuki muttered, cocksure. He gave a toothy grin that oozed arrogance. “In fact, all my partners are extremely satisfied afterwards, Deku.”

“I-I’m not talking about *that*,” Izuku hissed the last word with a large blush. “Get your mind out of the gutter and focus. Step one to pretending that you love your supposed *husband* you’ve been married to for *eight* years is holding his hand—”

“—We do that—”

“—Without being *forced*,” Izuku finished forcefully. “It looks weird that I’m the only one initiating touch between the two of us. You have to take the lead sometimes—*without* me stepping on your foot or poking you in the side.”

He shot a pointed glare and held up his hand for Katsuki to take.

The blond gritted his teeth and reminded himself he *asked* for this. Katsuki slowly took the smaller hand within his and intertwined their fingers without any struggle. He remembered how Izuku interlaced their hands yesterday and got it right on the first try.

He felt the soft part of Izuku’s skin under his finger pads again.

“There you go,” Izuku said happily. “Now, read from pages one to thirty while we wait. It’s a good example of how to behave when you’re pining after someone.”

“*Pining*?” Katsuki frowned deeply. As fucking if he would behave as though he was pining after fucking Deku. “Can we skip that part? I thought we were supposed to be madly in love already. Let’s cut to the established relationship shit. You know, where we ignore each other.”

“That’s not how that works if we’re supposed to be pretending to be in love. Pining doesn’t stop when two people get married, y’know.” Izuku gestured to the people around them who were giving each other lovesick stares. “It continues on if the bond is strong enough. That’s how relationships are maintained and two people can truly withstand anything that way. You want each other all the time and—”

“—I get it,” Katsuki groaned loudly. He waved his hand, shooing the invisible little hearts around Izuku away. “I fucking get it. *Please*, shut up. I don’t need to hear you rambling about this bullshit. I’ll read this whole damn book if I don’t have to hear you talk.”

Izuku rolled his eyes and pushed the book in his free hand. “Take this seriously. I don’t know how much more I can keep defending you when you offhandedly insult someone. Start absorbing this and when we get around the other couples, try it out.”

Katsuki grumbled and swallowed his pride.

He scraped together some motivation to get through this bullshit with some logic. He reasoned that he liked being the best at everything. It was one of his strong suits to be an overachiever. He was the best sharpshooter. Best hitman at The Company. Hell, from the reviews from his long list of sexual partners, he gave them the best orgasms they ever had.

Surely pretending to be a doting husband for a week wouldn’t be the thing to break his perfectionism streak. He hated love but he hated failure more.

He opened the godforsaken book to page one but stopped.

His heart twisted lightly—but he didn’t know why. Sitting on the inside on the back of the cover page was an endless sea of tally marks. They were small, precise and in different colored ink. The fadedness of some told Katsuki the ones at the top were old while the fresh blackness of the ones at the bottom were brand new. It was two hundred minimum marks.

He pursed his lips, wondering if these were counts for what he thought they were.

His eyes then skimmed over the first sentence of the novel.

“We are not the ugly parts of ourselves.”

Katsuki’s world halted as a chord deep in his dormant emotions was stuck.

For some reason, he didn’t expect a single word in this book to resonate within him. He anticipated every line to be mushy, lovey and all around too sweet for him to stomach. This opening line was the exact opposite, and it pierced a very specific part of himself.

Katsuki eyed Izuku curiously before deciding to take his impromptu homework seriously.

They laid side by side with their hands intertwined. The refreshing smell of the salty ocean filled his senses as they relaxed under the umbrella. Izuku closed his eyes and leaned his head back as they fell into full vacation mode. Katsuki diligently read, trying his best to think of it as full-on homework. Slowly, he found himself immersed in the scenes, analyzing the written emotions as time pressed forward.

After a while Katsuki came to a small conclusion about how to pretend to be in love better: touching.

The people in this book touched a *whole* fucking lot. Hugs. Random little brushes of the hand. On top of that, every touch *meant* something. It didn't feel entirely random. It appeared that every kiss or caress signified a silent translation of "I cherish this part of you."

It made Katsuki look up at the blissful couples around them slightly differently.

He watched a man kiss the beauty mark on his lover's shoulder.

Katsuki then turned his head to the peacefully quiet man beside him. Izuku was happily watching the band and the people dancing in the sun. The beautiful tranquil expression on his face disarmed Katsuki's defenses for a moment. There was a small glow around Izuku in the yellow morning sun. His skin was glossy, and his lips looked pinker than usual under the sun's hue. Scarlet eyes studied the thick, black eyelashes that were shading Izuku's eyes in a way that the green shade appeared darker.

Izuku contently stared at the happy couples through his pink tinted glasses. He seemed relaxed, but Katsuki could see the underlying hint of longing in his green gaze. Katsuki glanced between the plain text in his hand and back to his faux husband. He then scanned his eyes over a particular scene.

Meaningful touches.

He decided no better time than the present to practice.

Katsuki hesitantly lifted their interlocked hands and placed an experimental kiss on top of Izuku's hand. Right where the skin on his hand was softer than the rest.

Izuku snapped out of his daze immediately and turned to him. His floppy hat nearly flew off his head from the speed. Green eyes were wild and there was a deep blush racing down his neck.

"What are you doing?" Izuku asked tightly.

"What does it look like, idiot? I'm kissing your hand," Katsuki said as though it was obvious. He held up the book for context. "That's what they did on page twenty. Seems a little fast to me, but that's a normal affectionate thing between *pining* husbands. Right?"

"Oh. Ye-Yeah," Izuku said. He awkwardly readjusted his hat and blushed deeply. "Um, good job. Keep reading."

Katsuki raised an eyebrow at the odd reaction. “Oi. What’s wrong—”

“—Bakugous!” A loud, familiar voice boomed. Katsuki turned his head towards the source to see Inasa and Shouto walking towards them. “Hey! Nice to see ya!”

Both men were dressed in casual resort wear, shorts and floral print shirts. Shouto had a red floral-patterned shirt on. He looked happy and relaxed, as did his husband who was wearing a baby blue shirt. Katsuki’s eyes automatically moved to where they were holding hands, their sparkling gold rings shone in the bright sun.

“Oh, hello!” Izuku said automatically, enthusiastically waving with his free hand. Katsuki put the book down and gave a small wave. “I see you two wanted to try out one of the cruises as well.”

“Yeah, we want to maximize the experience,” Inasa said happily. Shouto gave a tiny thumbs up. “This one caught our eye because of how classy it is, and so far, so good. The views are fantastic! How are you two liking it so far?”

“We’re loving it so far. A little hard to fill the full time, but I don’t mind relaxing on the deck,” Izuku said easily. The two hitmen gazed towards each other, and Izuku gave his signature saccharine smile. They turned back to the two men in front of them.

“What my husband said,” Katsuki emphasized with a faux sincerity. “Just enjoying the sights.”

“We were actually going to go to the baking class, do you guys want to tag along?” Shouto asked with a relaxed smile. “It would be nice to have familiar faces around.”

“Oh, that sounds like fun!” Izuku said happily. “I’ve always wanted to learn how to make new pastries.”

He perked up again, in the same genuine way he did when they first got on the boat. Red eyes studied the joy radiating off the smaller hitman. Then he saw Izuku halt mildly and look at him with a reserved expression. There was a hint of shyness that he wasn’t expecting in that deep green gaze.

“B-But only if Taro wants to,” Izuku quickly corrected. He gave a sheepish smile. “We can stay here if you want.”

Katsuki sucked at his teeth. Why did Izuku give a shit about what he wanted? He could easily tell Izuku wanted to live this romantic paradise bullshit to the fullest. It was so obvious the nerd was tapering his excitement.

“No, let’s go,” Katsuki said finally. Green eyes widened by a small fraction. “It can’t be that bad. Let’s go make some stupid baked goods.”

☽ ☽ ☽

When they walked into the downstairs kitchen area of the cruise boat, Katsuki regretted his words. Why did he always make dumb ass snap judgements out loud? He should’ve stayed

on the deck reading that shitty romance novel while Izuku skipped off with Inasa and Shouto.

The whole kitchen was decorated with little, tiny paper hearts and romantic decorations. There was a chalkboard sign that read “Pastries for Lovers: Cooking up Chemistry” in white lettering. The handwriting looked as though someone spent a little too much fucking time on it. In Katsuki’s, not-so-humble opinion. Over their heads all too happy music played to set the false atmosphere of joy in all the cruise goers.

They took their positions at one of the many garnet tabletops. Waiting for each person was a frilly fucking pink and red apron. The upper half of it was in the shape of a heart and the whole thing was lined in white lace.

Shouto and Inasa took the opening spots next to them happily, acting as though they weren’t back in pastel hell.

Katsuki huffed out loud and crossed his arms. “Why is this place such a barf fest—”

Izuku discreetly elbowed him in the side harshly enough that Katsuki had to suppress a groan of pain. He stumbled slightly into the counter clutching his side and glared at the other hitman. Izuku gave a condescending smile.

Katsuki let out a shaky breath and grumbled as he put his apron on. He unhappily tied the strands around his waist, securing the hellish thing to his body. Izuku muffled some giggles the entire time, finding amusement in his suffering. Damn nerd was watching him as if he was putting on a show.

“You’re enjoying this view a little too much De—*Darling*.” Katsuki gritted his teeth as he blushed deeply.

“Oh, I am. This is priceless.” Izuku snickered. “It’s so fun watching you squirm, sweetie.”

Katsuki glowered deeply. Watch him *squirm*? Izuku always had such a smart-ass mouth. The green haired man tilted his head and quirked a brow as if this was one of the best checkmates he’s ever had.

Suddenly his itch to fuck with Izuku kicked in and he smirked. Which is why when the green haired menace grabbed his apron, Katsuki snatched it out of his hand.

“W-What are you doing—” Izuku hissed and Katsuki shook his head.

“Let me do it,” Katsuki scolded in a whisper only they could hear. He tutted his finger with a smirk. “We’re madly in love, remember? I'll put your apron on *for* you.”

Izuku blushed deeply but allowed it to happen, going along thinking it was part of the act. Katsuki carefully put the apron over his thick head of curls and then turned Izuku around. Izuku allowed him to tie the apron but when Katsuki cinched the strings with his full strength, Izuku’s breath dangerously hitched. Katsuki grinned sadistically as he pulled the strings tight enough that he heard Izuku mutter a curse.

He leaned down from behind and whispered directly next to Izuku's ear.

"It's even more fun watching *you* squirm, *darling*."

He tied it tight enough that Izuku had to restrain a groan. Katsuki stepped back and admired his work as Izuku immediately leaned against the counter clutching his stomach.

"Welcome to Pastries for Lovers!" A loud voice suddenly boomed. They both turned their sights to a man with dirty blond hair and a physique so fucking big that even Katsuki was impressed. "My name is Inui Ryo! I'm the head chef on board and I'm excited to get you all cooking up some chemistry!"

Izuku glared daggers at Katsuki as he readjusted the straps on his apron.

"This is one of my favorite activities because it'll be rewarding to enjoy a dessert you and your loved one made together!"

Several waiters dressed in the cruise's uniform came out and placed all the cooking utensils and ingredients in front of each couple's station. Katsuki looked down at the all the different assortment of ingredients carefully—but more so he looked down at the sharp knives. *Extremely* sharp knives.

Him and Izuku cut their eyes towards each other.

Well.

This had potential to be the worst misalignment the world had ever seen.

"We'll be making Boston cream doughnuts," Ryo said. He clasped his hands together. He put his own apron on, which was several sizes too small for someone his size. "You all can take them with you to share once you leave! Let's get started. I'll take you through it step by step!"

The instructor started taking them through it all, step by boring step. Part of Katsuki wondered why he agreed to this. Why the hell *had* he? But then he thought back to the rare look of radiant happiness on Izuku's face.

He pursed his lips, not really understanding the odd sensation of conflict in his chest.

Katsuki nearly sighed again, mostly frustrated with himself, as he started preparing to bake. However, he caught himself when Inasa and Shouto glanced at them and gave a friendly thumbs up. The happy married couple seemed like they were honestly enjoying baking together. It made Katsuki reel in his attitude when he comprehended that they were in front of other people.

He didn't want a repeat of the aerobics class, so he thought about those twenty pages he read.

Katsuki studied how Inasa rubbed Shouto's upper arms as he made a joke about the dough.

Touching.

Of course. Stupid, meaningful touches.

“Alright! For this step usually a dough mixer is required but, in this class, we think intimacy is the best mixer. You’re going to stir your dough mixture together for about five to ten minutes until it looks, well, dough like!”

Katsuki looked at Izuku who was already tentatively listening to the head chef and shuffling around the ingredients.

Izuku’s head bobbed between the instructor and the ingredients in his hand as he followed closely along. A tiny pink tongue stuck out of Izuku’s mouth in concentration as he whipped the mixture for the dough. He was rough and clumsy about it to the point Katsuki snickered. Izuku flushed deep with embarrassment until he yelped, some of the flour flying up in the air.

“Oh, whoops,” Izuku exclaimed and tried to reposition himself. “This is tougher than I thought.”

“Well, duh. When you’re doing it like that it’s going to be hard. Your technique is shit,” Katsuki critiqued. “You can’t just whack at it like you’re beating someone up, there’s an art to it.”

Katsuki then looked around at all the couples around—touching each other.

He cleared his throat before positioning himself directly behind Izuku. With their height difference he could see over the top of his bedhead of curls. Izuku craned his neck up and looked at him with a baffled stare at the proximity.

“People are, uh, around,” Katsuki excused lamely in a whisper. “Just trying to seem like we’re in love this time and not like we need counseling.”

To drive home his point, Inasa loudly laughed and held up his flour covered hands for Shouto and them to see. Despite them knowing it was all for show, it didn’t help quell the burning blushes on their faces. Izuku nodded in a hesitant fashion, facing forward again with the pink dough whisker in hand. Katsuki brought his hand over Izuku’s on the handle, nearly eclipsing the tinier hand with his own to guide the motions.

Warm. Izuku’s hand was always warm, Katsuki noted.

“You have to mix slowly,” the blond said in a low tone. He gently twirled the pink whisker in the bowl and naturally settled his other hand on the counter, trapping Izuku in. “Think of it like you’re still trying to get all the various ingredients mashed together. Flick your wrist a bit more—there you go, just like that.”

“Ah,” Izuku laughed lightly. From where he was at, Katsuki could see the deep blush on Izuku’s cheeks as he gave a tiny smile. It was once again pure and genuine. “Th-Thank you.”

Katsuki hummed. He guided Izuku’s motions a bit more, until it seemed like the tiny dork got the hang of it. Slowly, Katsuki retracted his hand, feeling the slight temperature change on his

palm from warm to cold. He moved to rest his hand on the other side of Izuku and loomed over him as he mixed the dough batter. He looked so damn concentrated to the point it was almost fucking cute.

“Have you ever baked before?” Katsuki asked, egged on by his budding curiosity.

“No,” Izuku admitted. Katsuki’s eyebrows raised up in surprise and Izuku’s blush deepened. “I-I always wanted to try though. So, this makes me really happy.”

Ah. That’s why he was so excited about it.

“Well, keep at it. If you need any more help, let me know De—er, Darling.”

“Will do! Uh, thank you. For showing me,” Izuku said quietly. “I appreciate it.”

“You’re...er, welcome,” Katsuki replied slowly.

There was a grave amount of tense silence as Izuku whisked the bowl of dough. It hit both men like an avalanche: this was quite possibly the most normal interaction they *ever* fucking had. Katsuki nearly didn’t know what to do next. He had helped Izuku with something and for once there was no snarky comment. No eye rolls. No sneer. And coupled with those facts, for an odd reason, he didn’t feel inclined to move his body away.

He intensely watched the blushing freckled man practice the new skill he had learned while trapped between him and the counter.

Katsuki then looked over and saw Shouto playfully kiss Inasa. The sight jarred him enough and made him a little too aware of the intimacy of their positions. His eyes flickered down to study how dangerously close Izuku’s back was to his chest.

Katsuki then pressed his lips in a thin line and finally pushed away from Izuku to get back to work on his own batch. He tried his best to shake off the normalcy of their interaction because it was fucking Deku. Goddamn Deku who shot him—who he *hated*.

Katsuki attempted to remind himself that Izuku was a menace. A short fucking menace. But every time that little giddy look sparkled in Izuku’s big eyes—Katsuki was beginning to waver on the title ‘menace.’

Time pressed forward and he and Izuku surprisingly worked well in the kitchen.

Izuku seemed shy about his lack of baking skills, but Katsuki taught him slowly. He reasoned it was only because he didn’t want to look like an abusive husband like yesterday—but it was begrudgingly fun seeing Izuku’s eyes light up whenever he picked up something new.

While they waited for the dough to rise, they chatted with Inasa and Shouto. The married pair was laughing and chatting with them happily.

“So, what made you guys choose this resort?” Inasa asked casually as he dusted off his hands.

“Ah, it just caught our eye,” Katsuki said easily. He eyed Izuku in a contemplative manner. *Touching*. He then placed his arm around Izuku’s shoulders. The freckled hitman easily leaned into him. “We saw one of those commercials for it and my husband here loves stuff like this.”

“Yeah!” Izuku grinned wide. “It’s been great. Everything is as advertised so far.”

The conversation continued through the time it took the dough to rise. He kept his arm on Izuku’s shoulders as the smaller man leaned into him all the way, looking visibly relaxed. As they were chatting, they learned that Shouto and Inasa had been in a relationship for nearly most of their life. They had known each other since they were kids and when they got to university, Inasa asked out Shouto on a date. Then during their university graduation, he proposed.

They were lifetime sweethearts. Izuku’s eyes nearly turned heart shaped while staring at them in awe.

Katsuki also learned more about Izuku in that time. Like how his stupid little face had dimples that showed whenever he tried to suppress a smile. Then the way his eyes almost looked brighter under the fluorescent lights whenever he talked about being happy to be in Okinawa.

When they returned to cooking, Katsuki pondered as he continued kneading the dough.

What if this really *was* a vacation to Izuku?

Katsuki huffed as he kneaded the dough thoroughly, letting out some extra aggression. Small flakes of the flour sprung up from and landed on the sleeves of his black shirt. Katsuki leered at them. He wasn’t about to ruin one of his favorite tops over something like fucking pastry making. He rolled his sleeves up until the hems were tautly around his biceps and got back to work.

As he was kneading, he noticed out of the corner of his eye Izuku slowed down on making the filling.

Katsuki slightly turned his head, wondering what the hold was up—but what he found wasn’t what he expected. Izuku was looking down, not even realizing Katsuki’s eyes were on him. A pastel pink blush was on top of his freckles as his green eyes zeroed in on Katsuki’s arms.

Katsuki faltered for a moment before realizing what was happening.

The damn nerd was *checking him out.*

Out of pure reaction to the staggering fact, Katsuki gripped the soft dough in his hands to restrain himself. Izuku’s eyes flickered from his arms down to the way Katsuki’s fingers sank deeply into the soft dough. The pastel blush grew deeper and then Izuku snapped his eyes forward and turned his face away from him.

Katsuki’s eyes widened from shock.

Fuck. Did he see that right?

“Alright!” The instructor’s voice cut through. “Time to roll down the dough and cut out the shapes.”

Katsuki’s brain struggled between paying attention to the instructor and staring down Izuku. The green haired man was blushing deeply, eyes so forcefully focused on his baking. Katsuki blinked rapidly wondering if he had hallucinated it—but he knew this wasn’t one of his lucid dreams. He had really caught Izuku checking out his damn biceps.

A large part of Katsuki’s ego swelled and he grew cocky.

He made it a point to roll out the dough with a slight flex of his arms to see if he could confirm his suspicions—and *yup*. Izuku’s eyes discreetly flickered over his muscles. The pair of hitmen placed the doughnuts into the oven and waited for them to bake. When it came time to take them out of the oven, Izuku was struggling to keep his eyes off his exposed arms.

As they went to the countertop side by side, Katsuki noted how Izuku was still blushing near him. The nerd tried to play it off with casual conversation—but there was a small hint of shyness that wasn’t there before.

He raised an eyebrow.

“Now you’re going to take your stick and punch a little hole in the doughnut,” The instructor said. He lifted the fluffy doughnut in one hand and a small stick in the other. He then used the stick to pierce through the pastry and swirled it. “Move it around in circles until the little hole is nice and gaping. This way you can put the tip of the piping bag in and put the custard in easily.”

Katsuki scoffed in disbelief.

“This is the most suggestive fucking baking class.” He used the little stick to poke a hole in the fluffy doughnut and twirled it around as instructed.

“What are you talking about?” Izuku said with an ignorantly cute smile. He did the same as Katsuki but with more vigor. “This is so relaxing and wholesome. We’re making cute little doughnuts.”

“Oh, please. You can’t be that goddamn naive,” Katsuki hissed. “These are nothing but metaphorical creampies in pastry form.”

“Stop being so crude,” Izuku harshly whispered. He glanced around wearily and then glared at Katsuki. “People can hear you so don’t say *that*.”

“What? Don’t say *creampie?”* Katsuki exasperated. He emphasized the last word a little too loud for Izuku’s liking. Several eyes turned towards them. “That’s exactly what the hell these are—”

“—Now once you get the hole all adjusted, it’s ready to be filled to the brim!” The instructor said gleefully. “Just insert the tip of the piping bag when giving the hole the custard. Nothing more. You don’t want to stretch your hole too wide.”

Izuku grimaced.

Katsuki gave Izuku a smirk when the freckled man started filling up the doughnuts. The off-white custard eased inside as Izuku applied pressure to the thin, plastic piping bag. When Izuku finished, a little bit dripped out from the hole in the doughnut and onto the pink baking pan.

“C’mon, nerd. Fucking *look* at ‘em.” Katsuki chuckled darkly. “You really don’t see it?”

“No. I don’t.”

Izuku glared at him with blushed cheeks and returned to the task of filling up the doughnuts. He had a pout on his pink lips that made Katsuki’s sadistic side rear its head. Izuku’s rose colored world was so romanticized to the point the man barely saw things as sexual. It was so obvious he always saw everything as cutesy and romantic.

Katsuki thought about how easily fucking flustered this nerd was and decided to test him limits.

As Izuku was meticulously filling up their batch of doughnuts, Katsuki picked up one that Izuku had already finished. Green eyes turned to him as Katsuki held it up with a cruel smirk.

“What are you doing? They’re not ready to be eaten yet—”

“—Creampies are *always* ready to be eaten,” Katsuki said mischievously.

His smirk grew as he lightly squeezed the pastry in his hand.

Izuku’s breath hitched as the cream came oozing out, dripping downwards. Green eyes went wide and stared at Katsuki like he had just committed a crime against humanity. But Katsuki didn’t give a damn when suddenly a small, heated tension sparked that neither anticipated. Izuku’s eyes flickered down to his arms and Katsuki’s smirk widened.

Burning scarlet eyes bored into deep viridian.

Without breaking eye contact, Katsuki lifted the abused pastry to his lips. He slowly dragged his tongue up, licking the trail of white custard that had dripped out. Izuku’s whole face burned red when Katsuki dipped his tongue in the hole, curling it enough to edge out a helping of the sweet cream.

Izuku squeezed the plastic piping bag so hard in his hands it burst.

Several people in the vicinity gasped in shock. Shouto and Inasa sharply turned to them and Izuku yelped loudly. He flinched when all the white custard splattered across his hair, eyes, mouth and nose. Large bits even went flying onto his apron and some of his shirt.

Katsuki's eyes bulged as he froze with his tongue deep in the pastry. Izuku quickly fumbled around to clean up. He was muttering a string of apologies as the thick fluid dripped down his face.

Crimson eyes dilated fully without Katsuki's knowledge.

Well, shit.

Izuku looked nearly sinful. All those conflicting emotions resurfaced in Katsuki as he stared down at Izuku. Half his brain screamed that this man had tried to kill him—the other half screamed this man was exactly his type in the looks department. But eventually all those swarming feelings of conflict were overshadowed by a *very* specific image put into his mind.

He put down the squeezed pastry when Izuku started to desperately wipe his face clean. The poor nerd's cheeks were burning red so harshly that Katsuki had doubts they would return to normal. Izuku kept muttering and wiping himself down to the point Katsuki felt a little pity for him.

When too many eyes were on them, he cleared his throat.

"C'mere," Katsuki muttered. "Let me help, you damn cultz."

He stepped forward and stilled the bustling Izuku by his shoulders. The short man froze in his grasp, not even daring to meet his gaze. Katsuki slowly took the napkin out of his hand, having some pity on him and helped him get cleaned up. Because that's what a good partner did: cleaned up their partner after making a mess. That's one lesson Katsuki didn't need help with.

When the custard dripped over Izuku's full lips, Katsuki found himself gazing a little *too* hard. He wiped it up, and damn. From what he could tell through the thin layer of fabric, Izuku's lips were plush and soft.

"You really exploded without giving me a warning," Katsuki mirthfully whispered, unable to help himself. "Got a little too excited?"

"S-Shut up," Izuku hissed, embarrassed. "It was an accident because you had to go and do *that*."

"In my defense, I didn't expect you to cream all over yourself."

Izuku spluttered and Katsuki's grin pointed ear to ear.

"Why—Why are you s-so—*so*—" Izuku tripped over his words before giving up. "I'm going to go clean up in the bathroom."

He blushed impossibly deeper and quickly snatched himself out of Katsuki's hold. The blond hitman chuckled deeply from his stomach, enjoying teasing Izuku too much. The cream covered man bowed out of the room and beelined straight for the restrooms—*yet again.*

Katsuki didn't even realize his smirk had blossomed into a smile until after Izuku departed. His cheeks hurt from the strain because he had not truly smiled in this long. The jump of warmth and happiness that surged through his veins was foreign—but it felt good.

He watched Izuku skirt around the corner with a quickness he had never seen the man have. But when the bundle of green and pink was out of sight, Katsuki thought about the visual of Izuku covered in custard.

He couldn't deny the man was a looker. Cute face. Plump ass. Soft voice. All physical attributes he liked in a man. But Izuku was even more attractive while covered in what looked to be something *very* dirty. However, while all that was obvious to Katsuki, he thought of Izuku's nervous reaction. It had made him chuckle so deeply that he liked it.

There was a trickle of warmth at the bottom of his stomach.

☽ ☽ ☽

While his faux husband was regrouping in the restroom, Katsuki finished up the baking.

He filled the doughnuts up, making a stupid little heart in red icing of on top of each one. He smirked at how they looked perfect. He privately thought to himself that he and Izuku had done a good job as he tucked the doughnuts in the pink box. He tied the black ribbon around the box.

When Izuku returned, he was as good as new. Not a speck of custard was on him and Katsuki nearly fed off the embarrassed glance Izuku gave him. That warm feeling at the bottom of his stomach returned.

"Well, it was fun making the little creampies," Katsuki said offhandedly. He handed Izuku the pink box filled with their creation. "We even got a little bow to top 'em off."

"Please. Stop it," Izuku begged. He snatched the box from him with a harmless glare. "If you don't be quiet, I'm going to punch you in the mouth to make you."

"Eh. Wouldn't be the first time, I could take it. Your left hook is weak."

Izuku huffed and turned away from him.

As they left the kitchen, Katsuki concluded: while he hated Izuku, he liked teasing him.

☽ ☽ ☽

They docked at Ie Island and gave their goodbyes to the Todoroki husbands. Shouto and Inasa mentioned that they were going to go exploring around and see what type of boutiques and restaurants the island had to offer. As they split ways, Katsuki concluded that they weren't that bad of company.

Two lovesick fucking fools—but nice men all around. More tolerable than the overly enthusiastic Ashido-Kirishimas in Katsuki's book.

The blond hitman placed his sunglasses back over his eyes the second the southern sun settled on him. He kept his sleeves rolled up to ease some of the heat blazing onto him as he held onto their pink box of Boston cream doughnuts. His muscles eased a bit under the tropical setting as the palm trees above their heads swayed with the ocean breeze.

Izuku's face had finally drained of all red blush after nearly an hour. A familiar, serious expression had now settled on to those freckled features. Katsuki took that as his cue to cut to business and ignore the budding feeling of warmth at his core.

"Alright, let's try to search for something out of place," Izuku said as they started walking in tandem towards the city area. "I feel like maybe there has to be more to the whole white dove thing than we see."

"It's probably code for something," Katsuki agreed. His eyes looked around the bustling island-goers. Nothing was suspicious so far. "What else does a white dove mean?"

"A white dove symbolizes three things usually," Izuku said easily, his own eyes glancing around as well. "Peace, love, and unity."

"Sounds like hippie shit. Maybe we need to find some bonfire areas."

"Or a church," Izuku suggested. "The dove is a religious symbol."

Katsuki nodded in agreement. Izuku was good at deciphering things—maybe all that time he spent with his nose in a book helped. He probably had a shit ton of symbolism fully loaded to use for moments like these.

As they walked around the city area of the Island, Katsuki admitted it was beautiful. Under the midafternoon light, all the lush greenery was breathtaking. He could see in the distance a thick forest. Above them the mountains and hills stretched towards the sky with the variety of palm trees. Birds flew overhead, chirping and singing their melodies into the wind. The sleek buildings of the city area were mostly made of glass and reflected the bright, white sun.

After combing through the area, they found a small church sitting off to the outskirts of the city. It was like most normal churches Katsuki had seen in his life. There were stainless glass windows aligning it in bright colors. They searched around it for any hint or direction of where to go.

Katsuki reasoned that if he was a human trafficker, he wouldn't give plain ass directions to his HQ. Too traceable. He would probably leave some weird clues that people who were smart enough to decipher would wind up finding it.

"Katsuki—look," Izuku suddenly said. He shot his hand out and grabbed his arm.

Izuku pointed upwards to the stainless glass windows above their heads. Katsuki looked up, fully taking a gander at them.

The images on the artful window were a flock of white doves flying towards the top of a mountain. Red eyes peered off into the distance to gaze at the mountain on the island. The

image was nearly the same as the landscape.

“Well shit,” Katsuki said. He tilted his head in surprise at how it was nearly a map of where to go. “A church was right on the money. Good job, Deku.”

“I told you I’m better at our job than you.” Izuku gave him a condescending bright smile and Katsuki glowered.

“Don’t push it,” Katsuki warned with a sharp gaze. “Actually, I take back what I said. Fuck you.”

Katsuki spun on his heels, irritated at Izuku’s small laugh.

They walked towards the mountain pass, passing by the sunny beaches along the way. People with surf boards excitedly ran past them in their bright swimsuits. Their giggles were light and cheerful as someone played music from their phones. Families having a day out sat under the palm trees that were perfectly aligned along the sidewalk. Some people were eating ice cream and chatting. Some people even had on big sun hats like Izuku’s as they lounged in the sand.

After a while, they came to the opening of a path that transitioned between the concrete of the city and up a small hill. It continued and followed a small trail up the mountainside into the thick foliage. The pathway was still lined with palm trees in an organized way that clearly had human help.

But as they trudged on, the once welcoming trees suddenly felt more ominous. The higher up they went, the less neatly aligned they were. The numbers started growing and with every step the concrete path started to appear more broken. The cracked concrete stretched up, looking as though they hadn’t been tended to for years.

It was when they reached a dirt road that the looming trees became so dense to the point they blocked out all the sunny sky above. Both Katsuki and Izuku put their sunglasses away into their pockets at a point when it became hard to see. The deeper they ventured, the temperature on Katsuki’s skin dropped in the dark shade. All the city noise became mute in the background and the only things Katsuki could hear were him and Izuku’s footsteps and breathing.

The aura was different up here. Izuku seemed to feel the shift in the air too, green eyes were now calculating and sharp as they strained to see around in the dense collection of trees.

Then there was a sudden rustle of footsteps the second the dirt path turned into nothing.

Both hitmen froze on the spot and in sync squatted low to the ground. They cut their eyes at each other in a silent exchange before reaching for their weapons. Izuku rolled down his pink socks to reveal a long fang shaped dagger and grabbed it with deadly intentions. Katsuki secured the box of pastries in one hand and hiked up his pants with the other. He reached for his loaded gun and secured the silencer on it.

They waited in the shadows for the footsteps to continue. It was two people, from what Katsuki could tell. The footsteps continued until they stopped. Rustled and shifted. Then walked off into the distance in the same direction he and Izuku were heading.

Katsuki jutted his head in the direction of the footsteps and Izuku followed suit.

They kept sleuthing in the dark until they came to a clearing and a large drop incline. They peaked over the declining hill to see what looked to be a grey warehouse sitting completely out of place. The lights were on, and it seemed like there was a large section of it that was embedded into the ground. Possibly leading somewhere. It was isolated, giving off an aura that caused goosebumps to dance over Katsuki's limbs. If he had passed this without knowing the assignment, he probably wouldn't have given it a second look.

But sitting on the side of the building was an emblem of a white dove carrying an olive branch.

Bingo.

"C'mon," Katsuki whispered and stood to full height. "Let's find a way down and survey the building. We need to confirm it's actually the headquarters."

Izuku nodded in agreement, and they backtracked a bit. They tried tediously to find a way down without hurting themselves. As they stumbled through the woodwork looking for a pathway down, they heard the footsteps come back.

They both froze as they looked around in the dense darkness. They ducked down to the ground again on their hunches as the footsteps grew closer. Katsuki carefully laid down the box of pastries on the dirt ground. He shifted his feet in a way that would allow him to go on the offense while Izuku shifted in defense. When the footsteps passed *directly* behind them, Katsuki spun around with his finger on the trigger and Izuku gripped his lethal dagger.

But both quickly staggered when they caught sight of the goddamn Todoroki husbands' backsides.

Katsuki hissed a curse as he rapidly fumbled to hide his gun and Izuku rapidly withdrew too. The Todoroki couple spun around the next split second to see Izuku and Katsuki fall into each other in the dirt in a clumsy attempt to hide their weapons. Katsuki and Izuku both groaned in pain as Katsuki accidentally went tumbling into Izuku without warning. His chin hit Izuku's forehead, and his body fell directly on top of the smaller one.

Neither of them cared about the awkward position as they desperately tried to conceal their weapons because what the *fuck*—

"—Bakugous?" Shouto exclaimed, eyes narrowing in confusion. "Is that you?"

Shouto's mixed matched eyes squinted in the dark as he and Inasa walked up to where they were laying in the dirt. Katsuki pushed his gun under Izuku's body and Izuku concealed his knife.

“Oh! H-Hey there, Shouto!” Izuku said lamely. He gave a smile as he tucked his hands under his back. “Yeah, it’s us.”

Katsuki concealed the fact he was on edge as he noticed how both Todorokis stances were discreetly on the offense. They each had one hand behind their backs and were eyeing them up and down. Katsuki and Izuku eyed them up and down right back.

“What are you two doing up here?” Inasa questioned. His once friendly voice was on edge and suspicious. There was no hint of the warmness from earlier as plain out confusion enraptured his strong features.

Izuku and Katsuki spoke at the same time.

“We were sightseeing—”

“—We were about to fuck.”

Izuku’s eyes went wide, and the two Todoroki husbands strangely eyed them.

Katsuki cleared his throat and gave a tight-lipped smile. He looked at Izuku to take the fucking hint. *Sightseeing*? In a goddamn forest where there was *barely* any light while they were laying on top of each other? Fucking was far more plausible.

“We wanted some—” How the hell did he put this? “—*Privacy*. The baking class admittedly put some images in my head. It made me a little impatient to get back to the hotel to have my husband.” A half-truth.

He smiled down at Izuku. He reminded himself that lovers touched and quickly wrapped his arms around Izuku’s shoulders, drawing him in close.

“Ye-Yeah,” Izuku tacked on, smiling as well. Katsuki felt him slyly hide away the dagger and gun under his pastel shirt. “Guilty as charged! Ha. Sorry. We’re kind of into the whole doing —*y’know*—in different places.”

Shouto raised an eyebrow.

Shouto and Inasa both shifted. They concealed an unknown item behind their backs before dropping their hands to their sides. The movement was so subtle that to the untrained eye, it looked like nothing. But to Katsuki’s blood-soaked scarlet ones, it was a red flag. He had no doubts that they were carrying either guns or knives.

Katsuki kept a poker face, realizing the seriousness of the situation.

“Ah. Well, risky business keeps the marriage fresh I suppose,” Inasa awkwardly chuckled. He gave a fake smile that Katsuki saw straight through. “You two are very adventurous to have climbed up here!”

“Yeah. We are. But what are you two doing here?” Katsuki questioned finally. He lifted himself up by his elbows, still entrapping Izuku’s body below him.

All four sets of eyes glanced between each other.

“We were just trying to see how far up the mountain went,” Shouto explained. Katsuki could see the man visibly force himself to steady his words—which meant that was a fucking *lie*. “We wanted to get a picture from the top of the mountain together during the sunset.”

“Well, the hiking path is the other direction,” Izuku said, forging innocence. “Just in case you guys are lost! We saw it coming up here. We went the other direction of it on purpose, heh.”

“Right,” Shouto said quietly without taking his eyes off Izuku. He turned to Inasa and touched his shoulder. “We must’ve made a wrong turn.”

Katsuki pressed his lips in a thin line. “Yeah. Must’ve.”

It was quiet enough to hear a pin drop as no one moved.

“Let’s go, Sho. We still have enough time to catch the sunset.” Inasa quickly said. He gave Shouto a tight-lipped faux smile.

“Alright. I guess we’ll be seeing you two,” Shouto quietly replied. “Stay safe and have...fun.”

He still stared down at their tangled bodies in a distrustful way. In contrast to this, Inasa brightly smiled at them like a flip was switched. Quickly the tension in the air melted into nothing and Shouto and Inasa seemed like normal everyday vacationers.

“Yeah, see you later for the boat ride back to the hotel!” Izuku said with a small wave and smile. “Have fun on the mountain top!”

There was a split second of distrustful glances exchanged. Then the Todorokis turned around and went towards the hiking path, glancing over their shoulders the entire time. Katsuki stayed positioned on top of Izuku until the pair of footsteps died off.

They both let out shaky exhales and Katsuki rolled off Izuku. He laid in the dirt next to him, sticks and rocks digging into his back.

For a moment the direness of the situation settled into their skins. It seeped in with each excruciating second. As they both gazed up at the thick canopy of palm trees, neither hitman said a word. They both replayed the entire interaction in their heads like a movie as they gazed up to the swaying palm branches.

“You know we have to go follow them,” Izuku said quietly.

Katsuki reluctantly nodded his head. “Yeah. I fucking know.”

This assignment was shaping up to be a bigger pain in the ass than he thought.

☽ ☽ ☽

They stealthily followed alongside the hiking trail until they heard a familiar pair of voices. As they crouched low, both Katsuki caught sight of Shouto and Inasa with their arms folded

looking just as equally baffled and tired as he and Izuku were. The crouched behind an inconspicuous bush and ease dropped.

“There’s something weird about the Bakugous,” Shouto said and Katsuki’s gut sank. Goddamnit. “I can’t put my finger on it but they’re off. First, they make a scene in the aerobics class and the baking class. Now they’re suspiciously having sex in the woods—close to the warehouse?”

“I think they just have marriage issues,” Inasa countered. “But I agree. It is a big coincidence that they were that close to the White Dove headquarters. It...feels strange. But I don’t believe they are associated with Moore.”

“Well, let’s keep a close eye on them and make sure they’re not working with him. My gut is sensing something is wrong.”

Well. At least they could confirm that the eerie warehouse *was* the headquarters. But that begged the question, who exactly were *they*—

“I hope you’re right and they don’t complicate things,” Shouto grumbled. “I swear, the captain does not pay us enough for these undercover operations. I could be back in Osaka with my father right now having a cup of coffee and working on easy misdemeanor cases.”

“I agree but think of it this way: once we get this case wrapped up, we’ll both be promoted to sergeants. I’m sure of it!” Inasa said enthusiastically. He leaned down and placed a small kiss on Shouto’s cheek. “The bust will be easy as cake and we’ll be on the first flight to Osaka.”

Both Katsuki and Izuku’s hearts dropped at the same time.

They were fucking cops.

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki didn’t know how to describe the rigid emotion that settled into his chest as he and Izuku walked back off that mountain. The air around them was stale as they absorbed the new information.

Two people in their goddamn Paradise Crew were fucking undercover police officers.

The gloomy overshadow of the canopy slowly dissolved as they walked towards the town area. The trees gave way back to that overly sunny sky that was now dusted with a light burnt orange. The clouds were absorbing the beginning pastel sunset and looked to be a mix of blue, orange and purple.

Neither hitman said a word as they walked aimlessly. Eventually Izuku announced that he needed to call his handler and Katsuki agreed that was the best move. They both ended up putting some distance between each other out of ear shot as they made their calls.

But of, fucking course that goddamn Aizawa didn’t answer. Katsuki pinched the bridge of his nose. Why the fuck could this man never answer in phone in a timely manner?

“Hello. You’ve reached my direct line. Things at work have picked up recently so I’ll get back as soon as possible. If this is Bakugou, you better come only bearing good news, my patience is thin with you.”

Beep.

Katsuki sighed heavily.

“Hey. So. We have a code secretive 110—like *direct* secretive 110. These people are very close to me every day. I’ll explain the situation in full but—” He looked over his shoulders to glance at Izuku. The green-eyed man raked a hand through his curls while talking softly on the phone. “—Some...*unexpected* things have come up. Give me a ring back ASAP.”

He ended the voicemail there.

Katsuki twirled the cell phone in his hand in deep thought. He watched a couple dressed in pink and orange walk by hand in hand.

He really didn’t fucking feel like getting called back to The Company without a completed assignment. He needed Moore’s head on a goddamn stake. Coming back empty handed would require so much protocol, debriefing and it would be a technical third strike in a row for missed missions for him. That type of faultiness always resulted in employees needing to make up *double* the assignments—and Katsuki was trying to fucking *leave*.

Eventually, Izuku came back and had a dampened mood dripping from him. His viridian eyes looked heavier—disappointed almost.

They began aimlessly walking.

Somehow, they found themselves on the beach, sitting in the sand under the golden sun. They sullenly watched the elegant blue ocean dance with the painterly sunset colors. Katsuki placed the pink box of doughnuts between them and leaned back to enjoy the view.

“Did you get any answers on what you have to do next?” Katsuki asked. He felt odd but he didn’t know why as he watched the sun begin to lower.

“No,” Izuku said with a tiny shrug. “I couldn’t reach my handler. I got our secretary—but he wasn’t much help and can’t issue direct orders. He told me to hang tight until our handler came back from overseas.”

Izuku was in the same boat as him. Katsuki dragged his tongue along the inside of his cheek while thinking.

“I can’t do cops,” Izuku confessed quietly without taking his eyes off the waves. “It’s strictly against my policies and outside of my operations. But I have direct orders that I need to take care of Moore—so cops are bad news.”

Katsuki nodded in understanding. “I can’t do cops either.”

Despite The Company having high end clients like specific political and government leaders, they still operated under the table. Cops were too straight forward in how they followed the law and regulated justice. Their world view would probably be shattered to know not everyone believed in the right to a fair trial. Police were too idealistic.

Katsuki liked to think of them like night and day. Police officers operated in the glorious sun. In contrast, he operated in the malignant shadows. He executed orders they couldn't and dished out balance in a way that was still too taboo for society to discuss. Because while Peter Moore was wanted dead or alive, many government officials were leaning towards death. Seemed like no one cared to go through the issues of a legal trial where their own dirty laundry might get aired out.

Katsuki sighed and took one of the doughnuts out of the pink box. He bit into it bitterly.

"What shitty ass luck," he grumbled as he ate. "I can't believe we're stuck with fucking *cops*."

"So. What now?" Izuku asked.

"I guess we wait to see what our higher ups say," Katsuki said distantly. "I can't make a move until I disclose the details to my boss. If he says abort the mission I have to head back. It's a stalemate."

"Same on the stalemate. I can't risk cops tracing me."

Katsuki hummed in agreement. He thought about the situation, and he was genuinely stumped. He had *never* had this happen before. What were the chances that he would have an obstacle like two undercover cops and the fact Aizawa was unable to be reached? He and Izuku were officially in limbo, stuck in Paradise together.

Damn. He guessed they were *actually* on vacation for a while.

A group of loud teens walked back on the beach with a loud radio blasting music. It faded into the background as Katsuki looked at the calm landscape. Katsuki took another of the sweet treats and motioned to the box.

"Try one of these creampies, nerd. They're actually good."

Izuku shook his head at him but didn't reprimand the crude language. He picked up one of the doughnuts and started biting into it. Izuku hummed in delight and leaned back in the sand as well. He put his sunglasses back over his eyes as the sun started to go down. Katsuki watched, interested, as Izuku laid down on his back and stared up at the clouds while eating.

"Enjoying yourself, dork?" Katsuki teased and tilted his head.

Izuku smiled up at him with puffed out cheeks full of pastries. "I am, this is sorta relaxing."

Katsuki chuckled lightly and shook his head. He studied as the colors on the beach started shifting to deeper hues. The gentle pastels became more vibrant and richer as the sunset grew near. The golden orange that was draped across the landscape encompassed Izuku as well.

Katsuki took that moment to really look at him. He looked at his cutesy clothes, his freckles and the dreamy look on his face as he stared up at the clouds.

It was then Izuku perked up and grabbed his bag. He took out the romance novel and handed it to Katsuki.

“You still need to finish the last ten pages,” Izuku said seriously. “You heard Shouto. We’re already suspicious to them—we can’t have any cracks now.”

“Yeah, yeah,” Katsuki mumbled. “I don’t disagree.”

The angry blond didn’t even try to fight it. He took the book reluctantly but flipped straight to where he left off.

As he read through the book, he realized it was good. There was no way in hell he’d admit it out loud to the menace next to him, but the book was decent. The characters were complex, and the story line was told in a nonlinear fashion that it gripped Katsuki’s interest and had him begging for more.

However, while reading the part where the man crossed a fictional desert for his loved one, Katsuki paused. He pondered if he could ever love someone that much—or could anyone love him that much.

He glanced up to see another couple walk by holding hands.

A small pang hit Katsuki’s sternum.

He finished the last ten pages without an issue, but slowly a gnawing feeling steadily consumed him. He felt out of place here like a sore thumb as he watched all the loving stares people were giving each other.

“What’s another way to pretend to be in love?” Katsuki asked, suddenly feeling like he wanted to know more.

“Um, you could do actions,” Izuku said thoughtfully. He tapped his finger to his chin. “You tend to just linger there and go along with whatever. But from what I know, people have love languages. Like touch. Giving gifts. Quality time together. Words of affirmation and acts of service.”

“Deku. Can you explain that to me in detail a bit more? You might as well have been speaking Cantonese when you say shit like that to me.”

Izuku lightly laughed and turned towards him with happy crescent moon eyes. “I mean the way you express your love for others. Romantic or platonic.”

Katsuki thought about it more. “Ah—okay. I get it. Literal fucking *love* languages.”

He mulled it over but didn’t really know what his love language was. Hell, he hadn’t even known there was any. He questioned deeply if he had ever expressed affection in such a way outside of sex with strangers he never saw again. He tried to think back to the only person

he'd ever loved—which was his mother. He was fiercely protective of her up until the day he fucked up and she got killed.

He supposed his love language...was...fuck. He didn't know.

He thought about his mother more, trying to connect anything.

But then as if someone had smashed a hammer to his spine, he involuntarily flinched and clenched his teeth. The image of his mother's bloodied, dead body resurfaced violently. He could see those lifeless red eyes looking up at him, filling every inch of his being with guilt and unchecked anger. He clenched his jaw so hard he felt the pain run down his neck.

No. No goddamn mom thoughts right now.

He quickly shoved all thoughts of her back in the steel volt in his mind and shut it tight.

Katsuki looked down at the well-used book in his hand to distract himself.

He instead focused on the fact he was stuck in Okinawa until Aizawa graced him with his presence. Knowing he was going to be here possibly longer, made him feel odd. However, possibly staying for a shorter amount of time made him feel odd as well. The former and the latter amounts of time felt bizarre to him for different reasons.

He stared down at the romantic man lying next to him trying to figure out why the latter made him feel strangely disappointed.

Katsuki then cleared his throat and tried to make conversation.

"It must suck that I'm the one you're stuck with while you're here," Katsuki said and held up the book for emphasis. "You clearly love this romantic shit. I feel like I cock blocked you almost—or er, romantic blocked? Is that a term?"

"No, it's not, but it's alright," Izuku reassured. He gave Katsuki a gracious smile under the orange sun. "Ironically, it's been interesting getting to know you. I finally got to know the personality of the annoying man who has been guarding my marks for eight years."

Katsuki scoffed and raised a brow at Izuku. "Oh yeah?"

"Yeah." Izuku grinned up at him mirthfully. "You're as intolerable as I assumed you were."

"And you're as much of a little shit as I thought you were." Katsuki smirked.

Gradually, they laughed together at the irony of their situation. It bubbled up slowly, building like a steady slow tempo until it reached a steady chuckle in both. Izuku snickered and smiled so hard that his eyes crinkled and Katsuki deeply chuckled until he felt that warmth trickle back into his core.

They laughed together for the first time, and it felt nearly harmonized.

Katsuki liked it.

He really did hate Izuku—but he liked this moment.

He listened to Izuku's laugh as he watched the sun finally set. All the beautiful colors around them slowly faded into desaturated blue darkness quietly. Everyone on the beach stopped talking and moving about to watch. For once, Katsuki felt his life halt entirely. There was nothing he had to do but admire the setting in front of him. The sun lowered itself with strength, confidence and an unnamed type of sadness below the blue horizon to finally rest for the day.

Both hitmen grew quiet as they stared at the sight in front of them, unaware of the set of light brown eyes watching them.

☽ ☽ ☽

It was now fully nighttime, and neither of them received a call back. Katsuki didn't know if he was okay with it or not. Izuku appeared a little on edge, but for the most part they went along with the motions. They had finished eating the dozen doughnuts they cooked, chatting lightly with each other and the truce they had felt almost real.

Katsuki's guard was let down a tiny bit as he watched the freckled man stuff his face with treats while wearing those dumb heart shaped glasses.

They boarded back on The White Dove with everything up in the air. They got back on deck and the upbeat beachy atmosphere now felt a little more slowed down and romantic. Instead of lounge chairs, there were now classy white tables for people to sit at on the deck. The fairy lights had more of an impact against the backdrop of the navy-blue sky. They almost put to shame the endless sea of stars twinkling brightly above them.

The pair of hitmen easily took a seat at one of the tables on the side to look out and admire the dark ocean view. Katsuki stared a little bit at Izuku's profile as the boat started to move. The wind picked up and brushed his curls back. At that moment, Izuku took off his heart shaped glasses and revealed deeper emotions inside of the sea of green in his eyes.

Katsuki's burning curiosity tripled the longer he looked at the sight in front of him.

Izuku stared off into the blended night sky and ocean as if searching for something. Katsuki tilted his head inquisitively as he considered the man in front of him.

He had always believed the first emotion he felt about the freckled man was anger. Unchecked, pure fucking resentment. He thought the bitter emotion coursed through him like a raging river and struck lightning on every nerve he had. But when he truly thought back on it—the first emotion he felt wasn't anger. It wasn't even hate or mild dislike.

It was morbid curiosity.

A shift of gears churned in his chest as Katsuki was finally honest with himself.

"Good evening, sirs," a waitress greeted. She did a light bow with the silver tray in her hand. "Pink martinis for your evening?"

Both Izuku and Katsuki glanced at each other before saying okay. She took the sparkling pink martinis off the delicate tray and placed it in front of them. A miniature, delicate hibiscus flower was perched on the side of the delicate glass. As they sipped on sweet drinks, the band was in the background playing slower music. Feeling like testing his music muscles, Katsuki decided to try to guess the temp range. It was *lento* if Katsuki had it correct. He listened a bit closer when the next song changed and found he was correct.

Then out of the corner of his eye he saw two figures approach them. Katsuki cut his eyes to see both Shouto and Inasa coming up to them with plastic smiles. He kicked Izuku lightly under the table to come back to earth from his thoughts.

“Taro. Hiroji,” Shouto said tautly. There wasn’t an ounce of trust in those eyes of his. Shouto slowly glanced between them and Katsuki could tell he was surveying them. “Good evening to you guys.”

“Shouto. Inasa,” Katsuki mirrored. He nodded his head curtly while Izuku happily waved. “Good evening to you too.”

“How did you guys enjoy your hike?” Izuku said with a friendly faux smile. He tilted his head, selling it fully.

“It was good. We got our photo,” Inasa exclaimed, grinning just as wide as Izuku. Katsuki now began to wonder how genuine his emotions were. “How about you guys? Did you um...have a decent time? Or get a chance to go elsewhere on the island?”

“We spent the evening at the beach,” Katsuki said. He took a sip of his drink. “I ate the creampie—I mean *doughnuts*. We ate the doughnuts we made.”

Inasa’s eyebrows shot up to the sky and Katsuki hated how well that fucking fit for their alibi. Izuku blushed deeply on the other side of the table and awkwardly chuckled.

There was a beat of silence between the four of them. Katsuki decided very quickly he didn’t like the way Shouto and Inasa were sizing him up. But before he could even begin to leer at them—a new figure appeared in all white.

Slowly an arm snaked around Izuku’s shoulders in false kindness. All eyes turned to the new figure and standing there in all his glory was Peter Moore. The resort owner’s smiling face was grinning ear to ear in all the false friendliness he oozed before. He was close to radiant in the night light under the fairy lights. He was decorated in multiple colorful hibiscus leis around his neck and clutched a few in his hand.

“Good evening Todorokis! Good evening Bakugous!” Peter Moore said with his award-winning grin.

“Good evening,” they all said in a clumsy unison.

Katsuki smirked lightly. Poor bastard didn’t even know one set of these husbands were trying to arrest him and the other was attempting to land a bullet in his skull without tripping

alarms. Katsuki had to take another sip of his pink drink not to snort at the thick fucking irony.

“I just wanted to come by and say hello!” Moore said a little too happily. “I always take the evening boat back over to the mainland. It’s a captivating ride. Fills my heart with joy and love every time!”

Katsuki began to wonder if this was even an act anymore. Maybe Moore wasn’t the fucking brains behind this—but then he reminded himself The Company never got a mark incorrect. This bastard was just that good at disguising the ugly parts of himself.

“Oh, by the way, these are for you,” Moore said as he lifted the leis. “I make sure to give them out to anyone who comes along the cruise.”

All of them let the man bestow upon them the string of flowers. He put a thick, deep scarlet Plumeria lei around Katsuki’s neck. Then he turned and put two bright pink ones on Shouto and Inasa’s. Then finally he gave Izuku the last one in his hand, a white orchid lei.

“And also, you all may have this, whoever wants it,” Moore said as he pulled out a tiny branch with green leaves on it.

Katsuki scrunched his nose. Why the fuck was he giving them a twig?

Izuku tilted his head as he took the stick out of the hotel owner’s hand. “An olive branch?”

“Mhm!” Moore agreed, looking at all of them with a charismatic grin. “I found it laying around and for some reason it reminded me of Hiroji’s eyes! I hope you don’t mind me saying this, Taro, but your husband has such a beautiful shade of eye color. Truly a beautiful find.”

Then before Katsuki could even respond to that weird comment, Moore placed the olive branch behind Izuku’s ear.

“Yeah,” Katsuki said tightly, looking between Izuku and the olive branch. “He has pretty eyes for sure.”

The olive branch was as delicate as Izuku’s facial features. However, there was an unsettling queasiness that settled at the bottom of Katsuki’s gut staring at it. He then wearily eyed the emblem of The White Dove that was on the boat’s flag, sailing high in the wind. He stared at the olive branch the bird was carrying.

Then he stared around and realized no one else on the damn boat was wearing a white orchid lei.

Katsuki glanced sharply towards Shouto and Inasa to see if they could sense the ominous nature of Moore’s supposed harmless act. But those two didn’t seem to be paying fucking attention at all, just playing with the pretty pink flowers around their necks.

When Moore gazed a little too long at Izuku, it felt like nails scratching down a chalkboard.

“Thanks for the leis, but I promised my husband a dance before you all came over,” Katsuki said suddenly. He extended his hand across the table for Izuku. “I want to make sure we have enough time to dance before the boat docks.”

“Are you ready, darling?” Katsuki said, gazing at Izuku expectantly.

He decided being near these three people was too many fucking liabilities. He hadn’t a damn clue why there was an eeriness looming over him—but he trusted his gut.

Izuku blushed but took the hand that was waiting for him. Katsuki intertwined their fingers, thankful for the warmth to some degree. The two hitmen smiled at all the three other men, and quickly they all said their goodbyes. Which Katsuki was fucking thankful for. When they walked away, he felt like he could breathe again. The suffocating air around the tension between the five men was simmering in a way Katsuki didn’t quite think was possible.

“They’re watching us for slip ups,” Izuku whispered. “This would be a good time to maybe strengthen our roles, not give them a chance to doubt us.”

Katsuki glanced over his shoulder to see Shouto and Inasa sit at a table and give a friendly wave. The two undercover cops sipped on their own pink martinis and started laughing. Katsuki huffed, agitated. Were they even fucking married?

They took their positions on the large opening. The brown wooden floorboards shimmered slightly under the twinkle of the stars and fairy lights around them.

“I have to confess, I have not a damn clue how to slow dance,” Katsuki whispered.

“Disappointed but not surprised,” Izuku said with a hint of humor. They turned to face each other and Izuku smiled up at him. “That seems on brand for you.”

“I’m guessing *you* know how to slow dance?” Katsuki sneered. “You probably think it’s some form of foreplay.”

“If that’s how looking at it helps you do it—then yes, think of it like foreplay,” Izuku said curtly. He put his free hand on Katsuki’s shoulder, and the blond was slightly taken back by the counter to his suggestive innuendo. “Now, put your other hand on my lower back,” Izuku said seriously.

Katsuki hesitantly slid his hand around Izuku’s waist to land at the small of his back.

He followed Izuku’s lead as they pressed in close to each other. Izuku squeezed their interlocked hand lightly. His body was warm and Katsuki felt himself unwillingly blush at the level of intimacy. Izuku started to sway lightly to the violin rhythm and Katsuki took a deep breath in as they went along with the music like everyone else around them.

Izuku was blushing, but it seemed like he didn’t let it get to him as they forcefully gazed into each other’s eyes to blend in. The music dipped into a rift that allowed Katsuki to lose himself to the delicate sound of the music. The longer he stared down into Izuku’s endless green eyes, the heat swelling at his neck seemed to grow in temperature.

He vaguely remembered hearing something about extended eye contact stimulating arousal.

“How long should we stare into each other’s eyes?” Katsuki asked after a while. He watched how Izuku swallowed, and his eyes flickered a bit to his lips.

“Long enough to be convincing—they’re still looking,” Izuku answered slyly.

Katsuki nodded and continued to sway to the music while studying Izuku. He swore Izuku’s palm spiked in temperature the longer they went on for. The candy blush on his cheeks were beginning to match his shirt again. Katsuki tilted his head, studying how the blush on Izuku’s face deepened the color of some of his freckles. Then scarlet eyes landed on Izuku’s full lips. Green eyes slightly dilated.

“What are you thinking about?” Izuku asked above a whisper.

“How this song fucking sucks,” Katsuki answered honestly. “They haven’t played anything fully tasteful this whole stupid boat ride.”

“I-I actually was hoping they’d play this one song, but it hasn’t come up yet,” Izuku said quietly. He finally broke eye contact and chuckled lightly. “It’d be cool to hear a violin cover it.”

Katsuki tilted his head at the sudden bashfulness. “What song is it?”

“It’s silly. Don’t worry about it,” Izuku awkwardly laughed off. He smiled up at him. He resumed eye contact with more purpose. “Let’s just keep going—”

“—No, seriously, Deku. What song?” Katsuki pushed. “Is it something from one of your little guilty pleasure romance novels or whatever?”

“It’s from a romance movie,” Izuku admitted. His blush deepened. “The setting with the boat and being on the deck is reminding me of this one scene.”

“Ah. Of course. You’re a nerd for romance movies too.”

Katsuki then hummed and broke eye contact with Izuku. He glanced at the band who was playing a song he didn’t care for at all. He then looked around and thought about how genuinely happy Izuku was earlier when seeing the romantic boat and then again when he was learning how to bake for the first time.

Katsuki clicked his tongue. “Go request the song you want played.”

“W-What?” Izuku stammered, not anticipating that. “No, it’s alright. People will think it’s lame.”

“Fucking go and do it you damn dork,” Katsuki emphasized with a smirk. “I can tell you’re practically drooling for it.”

Izuku looked at him cautiously for a moment before giving a genuine, thankful smile. Izuku broke away from him to walk up the band and Katsuki stayed rooted in place thinking about

how to properly slow dance. He touched his red lei and looked over to the two undercover detectives, who were still fucking discreetly watching them. Shouto was in Inasa's lap and to any mundane eye it looked as though they were just two lovers enjoying their company.

He grumbled wondering if those bastards could see through him and Izuku.

"Ah, they said they can't play it," Izuku muttered as he came back to where Katsuki was standing.

The blond sharply turned his head and frowned. "*What*?"

He paused, taken back by Izuku's crestfallen features. It made Katsuki raise his brows because the damn nerd nearly resembled a goddamn kicked puppy. His big eyes were glued downwards, staring at the floorboards and there was a hint of shame embedded in his face. He wrung his hands nervously.

"Why can't they play your sappy song?" Katsuki asked carefully.

"They said it would mess with the mood."

"So, they can play it," Katsuki corrected. He frowned harder. "They just won't."

"Er, yeah," Izuku confirmed sadly. "It's alright let's just keep dancing—"

"—Let's go talk to them," Katsuki quickly said.

He snatched Izuku by his elbow and dragged him across the deck. The smaller man was hissing protests and trying to get him to stop—but Katsuki ignored him. He yanked the man all the way across the boat. The sudden irritation ticking at his core was making him act out. Why? He wasn't sure. But the look of disappointment on Izuku's face was aggravating. He had suggested the nerd go play that damn song so he could be happy because he liked shit like this—only for him to get denied? No. They were going to play the stupid ass song.

He stopped in front of the band and looked over them. Red eyes dug straight into the lead violinist. The chords stopped abruptly.

"Oi. Why won't you guys play the song he requested?" Katsuki asked with narrowed eyes.

"Oh, it-it's too fast," the brown-haired violinist said. He awkwardly lowered his instrument, gazing between the cringing Izuku and pissed off Katsuki. "We're staying in the low tempos today—"

"—I don't give a flying *fuck*." Katsuki hissed in a threatening tone. "You guys have been playing tacky ass songs all night. No one gives a rat's ass what tempo it's in when it's making their ears bleed. Play the song he asked for."

"B-But sir, we have to follow protocol."

Katsuki's eyes darkened and all the fury of a thousand storms threatened to unleash as he glared into the violinist. He leaned down with the most intimidating leer to grace his features.

He stared straight into the cowering man's eyes and curled his upper lip.

"My goddamn husband said he wanted that fucking song played so *play* it."

Katsuki's voice was so low and menacing that the violinist instantaneously straightened out. The brown-haired man cleared his throat and gestured to the rest of the musical team with some fancy hand motions. He resumed position with his brown violin and began playing the song that Izuku requested.

Katsuki immediately recognized it.

"The fucking *titanic* song?" Katsuki exasperated.

He looked down at Izuku baffled—shocked—but somehow not surprised in the slightest.

"I like it," Izuku confessed with a timid smile. "It's pretty and it fits the setting."

Katsuki sighed, realizing he made a fucking scene over Celine Dion.

However, as the music played, Izuku's face slowly melted off that disgruntled expression and a new one blossomed on it. That same genuinely happy gaze was back and the warmth at the bottom of Katsuki's core struck again.

Katsuki shot one last glare at the violinist who flinched in fear. He resumed holding Izuku's hand and they took their spot back on the deck and danced along to the music. He had to admit, it was pretty. Izuku started laughing and poking fun at his outburst, but Katsuki shrugged. The gentle breeze carded through his hair as they swayed to the song.

Under the stars like this, Katsuki quietly agreed with Izuku.

The song did fit the atmosphere of the cruise boat.

The sound of the ocean waves blended with sound to make the perfect melody as they lost track of time. The corner of Katsuki's lip tugged upwards as he looked at Izuku under the lights in the white lei and olive branch in his hair.

Neither noticed how Shouto's and Inasa's eyes softened while looking at them. The pair of undercover officers glanced at each other before leaving the boat deck to go enjoy their evening together.

☽ ☽ ☽

They arrived back in their hotel room in limbo. Katsuki stripped down immediately, showered and was thankful he was back inside. He pondered over what was going to happen now. For the most part it was no big deal. They just had to chill out until someone called them back. They could handle that—maybe take a couple days to just watch TV and sleep in the room. When he emerged from the bathroom, he was surprised to see Izuku sitting frozen in thought on the edge of the bed still fully dressed.

He was hunched over, and a pensive expression was pinned to his face. The green-eyed man had taken the olive branch out of his hair in deep thought. He twirled it in his fingers lightly.

“I was the only one Moore gave a white lei to tonight,” Izuku said without taking his eyes off the branch. “And this plant. It could just be a weird alignment, but do you think that means something?”

Katsuki pressed his lips in a thin line. He walked up to Izuku and plucked the twig from his fingers, examining it carefully.

“Yeah,” Katsuki said honestly. “Don’t know what yet, but it felt intentional.”

Izuku nodded emptily as Katsuki laid the olive branch on the nightstand.

☽ ☽ ☽

That night, Katsuki didn’t dream. Or maybe he did and didn’t remember it. He wished he had, feeling oddly attached to the lucid dreams now after two consecutive nights. All he could vaguely recall from his distant dream memory was the sound of violins. Once again, it was that same unique melody that haunted him.

They were woken up the next day by a loud pounding on the door.

Katsuki had jolted awake while Izuku groaned grumpily. Red eyes squinted in the bright fucking sun as he looked at the clock. It was fucking 06:02 in the goddamn morning. Who the hell was waking them up—

The pounding counted until Katsuki angrily yelled out, “Hold your fucking horses, we’re coming!”

Izuku tousled in the sheets. He unhappily sat up and both hitmen looked at each other over the pillow barrier on the bed. Katsuki grouchily arose shirtless and scratched his ass through the black boxers. Izuku yawned loudly as he rubbed his eye with the oversized pink pajama top sleeve. They walked up to the door and Katsuki grumbled as he snatched it open.

“Why the hell are you knocking on our door this early—”

“—Surprise!” A loud unison yell from the Ashido-Kirishimas belted out way too goddamn loud.

Katsuki felt murderous. Well, more murderous than usual.

Standing in front of them was their entire paradise crew. The Todoroki husband looked grouchy as well, as if they too were dragged out of bed to be here. Momo and Jirou looked decently awake enough. In their hands were plastic coffee mugs with black caps. And right in character were the Ashido-Kirishimas: bright and fucking sunshiny holding what seemed to be—camping gear? Katsuki blinked rapidly and then noticed all their Paradise Crew was indeed dressed as if ready to go into the woods.

“What is this?” Izuku asked through his thick sleepy voice.

“Yo! Get this,” Eijiro said, looking a little too excited for Katsuki’s taste. The red-haired man held up a bundled pink sleeping bag. It was decorated in small hearts and Katsuki had to hold back his gag reflex. It was way too early for this. “We won the resort lottery! We get access to the camping grounds for two days in the Yanbaru forest—for *free*! We’re getting a car and everything to travel up into the mountains!”

“And how *exactly* did we win this lottery?” Katsuki said unamused.

“Oh, the resort owner, Mr. Sekai, told us this morning,” Mina said happily. She clapped her hands together. “He said that they pulled our group number out of the lottery. I’m so excited!”

Katsuki’s gut instincts flared. “Sekai. Sekai is inviting us into the woods?”

“Yup. All expenses paid,” Momo said. She sipped her coffee. “Usually, it’s an extension package couples can add on to their resort experience. It’s super expensive though—but this should be interesting.”

“Yeah. Interesting indeed,” Shouto quipped.

Katsuki suspiciously eyed the olive branch on the nightstand.

Chapter End Notes

Thanks so much for reading! Please leave a comment with theories, screams, connections you've made. I enjoy and feed off reactions. Super excited for the next chapter :)

Chapter 5: Adagio

Chapter Summary

> Adagio (tempo): Slowly, leisurely

Chapter Notes

> Welcome back! Here's a fun chapter for you all. I hope you enjoy it. First off, thank you to the moon of my life, LunaToons on AO3, for beta'ing this chapter and this fic! I hope you all like it.
>
> **Warnings: Minor Character Death/Homicide**

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 5 - Adagio

.

.

.

Katsuki was a single moment away from losing his goddamn mind.

This assignment truly was testing not only his patience, but his sanity. At this rate, he wasn't sure which was going to cave first. He was damn close to saying fuck it, walking up to Peter Moore and shooting him on general principle.

Currently, their crew was waiting downstairs for them as he and Izuku packed their bags to go camping in the Yanbaru Forest. They were given camping gear in hiking bags with their respective names pinned neatly on them. All the backpacks were filled with the gear they needed. Everyone's hiking backpack was the usual grassy olive color that was found in outdoor gear.

However, Izuku's was a different color.

Izuku's was white.

"You're aware this is suspicious, right?" Katsuki asked as he finished getting dressed. "First the white lei, the olive branch and now your bag is a different color than everyone's. White

on top of it."

"Of course, I am aware," Izuku said seriously. He pulled the ivory hiking bag on and secured the straps. "But until I hear back from my handler, I can't make any serious moves with *police* breathing down my neck. I need to lay low and *stay* low."

Katsuki cocked his gun before he zipped it in his bag.

"Just keep sharp, Deku."

They finished getting dressed and walked out of the hotel suite side by side on high alert. Katsuki was wearing black cargo shorts, a charcoal black flannel and underneath a black tank top. He put his black boots on, and this time put his guns in his bag instead of on his person. In contrast, Izuku had on high waisted khaki hiking shorts and a salmon-colored t-shirt. He was wearing pink hiking shoes with normal ankle high socks.

On his collar bone was another band aid—covering up his numbered tattoo.

That small detail made Katsuki wonder a bit. It seemed like Izuku made it a point to cover it up every time his shirt's hem was low. He stared at it a bit as they walked, which earned him a curious gaze from Izuku.

"You're staring again," Izuku said casually. "Are you sure you think I'm an eyesore?"

Katsuki immediately frowned and snatched his eyes away. "The ugliest eyesore there is, Deku."

Izuku shook his head as they continued downstairs.

They walked into the lobby, and immediately Katsuki could feel the burn of a million eyes. Several inconspicuous hotel workers glanced at Izuku's backpack. Any other time, he would've summed it up to Izuku's God awful clothing choice. However, this time felt different. Each set of eyes that landed on them felt like they were assessing them.

A little too closely.

He was holding off on the worst-case scenario in his mind, but he knew what was possibly happening. Izuku was being targeted by Moore. The white colored gifts were probably the equivalent of the goddamn bat symbol in the sky for his lackeys for the next victim.

When they made it to the parking lot, they found their crew loading up a bubblegum pink minivan. It was decorated with white hibiscus floral decals and on the side said "Paradise Camping" in magenta print.

Katsuki's worries about the white backpack were immediately buried. He felt the aneurysm growing in his stomach at the sight in front of him and restrained from cursing.

"Hey guys!" Mina said with a bright smile. She was wearing purple butterfly shades and casual hiking gear. "You made it just in time, we already loaded up the car. It's a tight fit but we got all the stuff here! Put your bags in when you have the chance."

“This is going to be hell on wheels,” Katsuki grumbled under his breath only for Izuku to hear.

“Just remember to smile,” Izuku said with a shrug.

They loaded up their backpacks into the minivan and it was stuffed tight. When it came time for them all to get into the godforsaken van, Eijiro got in the driver’s seat and Mina took the passenger seat. Momo and Jirou sat next to Shouto and Inasa in the middle. However, in the third row in the back there was a lump of luggage.

Katsuki frowned.

“There’s not enough room for us in the back,” he announced. He put his hand on his hip and gestured unhappily to the pile up of duffle bags. “You all put your shit on the seats.”

Mina peered back curiously but then smiled at him like there wasn’t one fucking seat.

“Oh! Yeah, it was a *really* tight squeeze. But we figured you two could share a seat together!”

Both hitmen blushed beet red. Share a goddamn seat? With *Izuku*? Heat raced all the way up to Katsuki’s cheeks as the thought made him absolutely scandalized.

“You’re shitting me. Why the hell would you think *that*?”

“B-Because Hiroji is small enough to fit on your lap,” Mina explained. She glanced between them, unsure of why it would be a problem. “Unless you don’t want him on your lap, then maybe we can shift seats around. Sorry that we assumed—”

“—I-It’s alright!” Izuku quickly interrupted. “It’ll be fine! C’mon sweetie, let's get in the car.”

Katsuki’s eyes nearly popped out of his head.

He gritted his teeth so hard together to stop from erupting in anger that he was sure his dentist could feel it. Izuku shot him a look that said *‘let’s just do it*’ because they were around people —but Katsuki was not prepared for this.

He swallowed and tried to dissociate when he took his seat in the back.

It was an extremely tight fit for an hour car ride. The bags on his right were pressed into his side, boxing him in. But despite this, he reminded himself: this was his *last* goddamn assignment. Maybe whatever deity up there had thrown in all these goddamn trials to make sure he got his stress gauge filled before departing.

He settled one arm on top of the duffle bag pile up as Izuku climbed into the back seat.

Green and red eyes met each other for a split second. The rush of burning embarrassment sparked between Izuku and Katsuki. Izuku turned around and awkwardly settled into his lap and Katsuki resisted cursing.

Izuku's ass was plusher than he assumed it would be. He thought at first it would be a balance, mostly muscle with maybe a tiny bit of soft cushion—but from what he could feel through their two layers of clothing, Izuku was mostly cushiony. Probably explains why his ass was always so damn soft and jiggly looking.

"Alright! To Yanbaru!" Eijiro said. He gave an enthusiastic fist pump. "Seat belts on everyone! Remember, safety first, it's going to be an hour ride!"

Izuku muttered an apology as he wiggled in his lap to get a better fit. When it seemed like Izuku was finally slotted against him, he buckled them in. Their lower halves were snuggly fitted together in a way that suggested many things to Katsuki. Izuku tensed up, clearly uncomfortable and Katsuki just knew there was someone in the sky above laughing at them.

The car started to pull off, and Jirou took the audio cord to start playing music for them all to enjoy. Soon the cramped space was filled with jokes, laughter, and songs as they began their journey.

The green-eyed man leaned against the window, eyes soaking up the vast landscapes that whizzed past. Katsuki turned his head too, deciding to watch the makeshift motion movie. As they drove further north, the rich city scape started to fade. Modern architecture and palm trees turned into more traditional buildings with various greenery.

Then once they hit the forest area, it was a viridian explosion. In the distance was an endless stretch of mountains covered in trees, and the foliage took root everywhere. Gravity pulled both men backwards a bit as they began the incline upwards. Katsuki was nearly breathless at the full view of the subtropical forest.

Keyword: nearly.

Frigid eeriness prevented appreciation from fully settling in. The premonition in his bones started aching deeply. He pulled out his cellphone and Izuku did the same.

Both hitmen glanced at each other wearily as the car went further up the mountain. While the view was stunning, Katsuki couldn't enjoy it. The feeling in his gut tightened when the service bars on his phone dropped one by one as they went further into the vast forest lands. He looked over at Izuku's phone and the same thing happened.

Then when the bars finally hit zero, he saw two words that were probably the worst thing in the world: No Service.

Katsuki cursed and he could sense Izuku grow unhappy as well.

The pull of a damper feeling hooked into his chest. He *really* fucking hoped Aizawa didn't call him until he could find a location with service. Possibly the top of some hill or mountain. He could already hear the angry voice his supervisor would use on him for dropping the fact there was a code 110 and then *not* answering the phone.

Within time, the smooth concrete started to shift into unsteady dirt paths.

The van hit a couple of bumps and rocks the further into the forest they went. Katsuki bit his lip when it created a level of friction. Of course. Of-fucking-*course*. He could feel the stimulating heat under his collar. It just had to be *Izuku's* ass. Izuku's naturally round, perky, plump—

—*Fuck*.

Stop that. This is fucking Deku. Green menace to society and little thorn in your side.

Katsuki clenched his jaw. He tried his best to ignore the fact he was getting hard. The pressure from Izuku's soft backside was directly on his cock and with every turn, the bumping made his hard-on grow thicker. He leaned his head against the headrest and closed his eyes. He reminded himself to breathe. This hell of a car ride would be over soon.

But suddenly Izuku grinded down on him.

Katsuki's eyes instantly shot open.

There was no fucking way. That had to be a mistake, right?

But then the car bumped around again, and Izuku squirmed in his lap. The little shit's wiggles sent ripples of a very familiar heat into Katsuki. He tightened his fists to stop from overreacting and making it more awkward for them. Maybe Izuku was shifting to get comfortable—which wasn't good for *Katsuki* but he could deal.

He pressed his lips tightly together when he felt his erection slot *directly* between Izuku's cheeks.

He felt all the blood rush down to the one fucking place he didn't need it to be. As the car ride got bumpier, Izuku wiggled more. Then he started flat out squirming downwards with every bounce in Katsuki's lap. Without warning, his brain provided very specific images of Izuku eagerly bouncing on his lap for an entirely different reason.

No. Katsuki pushed down the lewd vision and shook his head against the headrest. *Nope. Absolutely not—we're not fucking doing this.*

He shot a hand forward and yanked Izuku backwards by the collar of his stupid pink shirt. Izuku muffled a small yelp as his back was pressed against Katsuki's chest. The flustered blond pushed his lips right against the shell of Izuku's ear.

"The hell are you doing?" Katsuki harshly whispered. "Stop grinding down on my dick—what the fuck?"

Green eyes went wide and Izuku paled. "Th-That isn't your gun?"

"My gun? Of course it fucking isn't."

"B-But it's so—"

"—*Hard*? Yes. Now stop wiggling."

“It’s poking into me and making it uncomfortable to sit.”

“Just relax,” Katsuki nearly growled. He moved his hands instinctively to Izuku’s hips to hold him steady when the damn man squirmed again. “The more you move, the more *uncomfortable* it’s going to get for *both* of us.”

He could hear Izuku nervously swallow. “O-Okay, I’ll try to sit still.”

Izuku nodded, and he curled his fists anxiously on his own lap. Katsuki expected Izuku to lean forward—but instead he stayed with his back pressed against his chest. From this angle, Katsuki could see that deep pink blush paint all the various freckles on Izuku’s nape. They hit a rather hard bump and he could hear Izuku restrain a whine.

Katsuki gripped Izuku’s hips firmer in a failed attempt to keep friction from forming. But with every bump, he found himself steadying Izuku in his lap. It was beginning to be worse than the freeform bumping, and a lot more suggestive. Against his better judgement, Katsuki wondered what was going on in that thick head of curls when he heard a light gasp. But he was given a very good idea when he glanced down at Izuku’s lap.

Izuku’s small hands were failing at covering up the tent in his shorts.

Scarlet eyes went wide and Katsuki’s brain nearly short circuited.

Another bump.

Another muffled whined.

Katsuki stared at Izuku’s lap hard enough to burn holes through his shorts. He watched the man press down on his erection in an attempt to be discreet. The fucking nerd was trying to hide how he was turned on *too*. Which, *holy hell*, was groundbreaking to Katsuki. The heat prickling at his skin nearly tripled at the realization that Izuku *liked* a cock poking into his ass.

Before he could process the sweltering shift in the air, the van came to a jerking halt.

“Alrighty! We’re here everyone!” Mina’s jovial voice rang out.

Everyone cheered except Izuku and Katsuki who were too busy dealing with their current problems. All the other people in the car started getting out and the trunk popped open. Izuku made a move to leave, but he was halted by the large hands holding his hips in place. Izuku’s breath hitched when rough fingers dug into his soft skin.

“U-Um. Can you let go of me?” Izuku whispered bashfully.

He turned his head to see Katsuki staring down at where they were pressed together. Gradually, burning scarlet eyes dragged up his body to meet his deep green eyes.

They maintained eye contact and Katsuki slowly let go of Izuku’s hips without a word. The blushing freckled man nodded, mumbled a small ‘thank you’ and stumbled out of the car

with a quickness. He took his floppy hat off and placed it over his crotch area in an attempt to be modest.

Katsuki snapped out of his daze and placed his hand over his mouth in shock.

Fuck.

He could still feel the warmth from where Izuku had been plastered up against him. It had kicked up all those conflicting feelings he had about the other hitman once again. The same feeling that birthed in Vienna, took flight in the aerobics workout and soared high in the baking class. Now it was fully eclipsing the rational part of Katsuki's thoughts.

Suddenly, the fact that he had been nearly killed by Izuku on several occasions didn't seem like a big deal.

He stayed rooted in the car to rid himself of the very dirty thoughts playing inside of his head. They featured a certain hitman who had the softest ass in the world. He tried to will away his erection, but he was immensely unsuccessful.

"Hey, c'mon, Taro! We need your help with the bags," Momo called out for him.

"Coming," Katsuki grumpily answered.

☽ ☽ ☽

The first thing Katsuki truly studied was the subtropical atmosphere.

The air smelled like crisp oxygen, greenery, and campfire. It was a breath of fresh air as trees stretched up to the sky, they were taller than anything he had seen in person. He could hear the tranquil sound of running water off in the distance as the harmonization of birds chirping echoed all over. The bright sun shyly peaked through the canopies to sprinkle down various sunspots onto the dirt ground.

The campsite itself was endearing and was composed of a large clearing. Several other campers were also here, set up in different private nooks. Each space in the campsite had room for a van, several tents, and a placement for the campfire in the center. The burnt smell of the flames from another group lingered into Katsuki's nose as they walked up to their designated space.

Maybe this won't be so bad, Katsuki thought to himself. He liked hiking.

They all began leisurely setting up their separate tents. It wasn't too bad of a task, but fucking Izuku could barely meet his eye. It was as if Izuku was a trained ballet dancer with the way he was expertly avoiding and skirting around him. The green-eyed man barely spoke as they pieced the pink tent together. Katsuki too was feeling oddly flustered. Izuku acted as though being around Katsuki for too long would be like tempting a snake to bite him.

By the time they finished settling in, all Katsuki could think about was the fact Izuku had been sitting in his lap. *Turned on*. For only Kami knows how long.

“Alright. Here’s everyone’s sleeping bags,” Shouto said. “There’s one for each pair of us it seems like.”

He gave each couple what looked to be one big ass sleeping bag. It was pastel pink—of fucking course—and large enough for two people with a snug fit. When Shouto shoved the horrid item into Katsuki’s hands, the realization sunk into both flustered hitmen.

They grew quiet in the already thick tension. Katsuki cursed everything under the sun as he walked over to his and Izuku’s tent and unceremoniously threw the damned thing inside. That was a problem for later he decided. When he walked back, everyone was standing around looking happy and eager to get going on their adventure.

“What should we do first?” Jirou asked happily.

Immediately a chorus of suggestions sprung up.

“Hiking!” Eijiro said. “We should get some steps in!”

“Oh, let’s try to get kayaks and go down the river!” Mina suggested. “I always wanted to try out forest kayaking.”

“Sleep,” Katsuki grumbled. He folded his arms and sneered. “You guys woke me up at the ass crack of dawn.”

“I think I saw a small lake on the way up,” Momo suggested. “We can go hiking and then stop for a dip. It’s super-hot out and that would be a fun way to unwind.”

Everyone looked at Momo and then slowly nodded and agreed with her.

Katsuki agreed too, being a fan of hiking. Maybe he could get himself in a different headspace while doing an activity he enjoyed. Preferably a headspace that was void of thinking about Izuku being turned on while lightly gasping in his hold.

Katsuki and Izuku glanced at each other for one second before Izuku blushed deeply.

Green eyes snapped away from him within the next moment, as if dreading something.

☽ ☽ ☽

As they hiked with the group, originally it felt tense. Both he and Izuku checked their phones discreetly, seeing if they could get any service. But each time, they found nothing.

The reality of the words ‘No Service’ hit Katsuki upside the head like a wrecking ball. They truly were off the grid and had no choice but to go with the leisure motions. As their group continued on, they kept sharp from anything suspicious connected to Moore—but for the most part there was nothing.

Just beautiful greenery on top of more beautiful greenery.

They reached the top of one hiking trail that opened out to a gorgeous vantage point. From this angle, it looked like all the mountains beneath them were a sea of viridian. As though the endless inclines and dips were permanently rocky waves embedded into the earth.

He turned to his side to see Izuku looking just as astonished at the scene.

Katsuki couldn't help but think how seamlessly Izuku blended with everything here. His unruly curls, his large green eyes, and his freckled skin were almost camouflaged into the forest. Even the various hues of green around them were the same ones clustered in his eyes.

Their party ended up taking photos, having laughs, and growing slightly closer along their hike.

After a while, Katsuki put his phone away. He accepted defeat when they went up and down several trails as a group.

He thought he would be annoyed, but the truth was it was probably the most peaceful thing Katsuki has done in a while. He always liked hiking—or liked the idea of it. He did it a couple times when he was in high school before The Company started having him work full time.

He couldn't recall the last moment he took time out for himself. Like truly for just himself—not on call waiting to get dragged to go handle some bloody business.

But now, for the first real instance in nearly a decade, he stared up at the sky without thinking too hard about the time. His chest felt as fluttery as the birds above them, and his muscles were eased.

They kept on like this for an hour, following the hiking trails deeper. Their crew was mindful not to fall over any cliffs or sharp ledges on the unruly dirt paths. As they ventured further into the forest, the steeper the inclines and declines became.

It made Katsuki a smidge worried, but the entire time they were guided by the signs that read 'Hiking Path This Way' and avoided the red ones that said, 'Dead End.'

When they finally reached the last fork in the road, they found themselves at the small waterfall that opened into a lake.

It was nestled privately in a nook far away from the campsite. The foliage, vines and trees were dangling over it as if protecting the small haven from the outside world. Above there was a small cliff perched over the lake where the waterfall poured a light stream of water down below. The soundtrack of the wildlife chirped, buzzed, and harmonized in the background.

"Whoa, this place is magical!" Eijiro said happily. "Like a subtropical sanctuary!"

The redhead grinned and set down his hiking bag on the ground by the lake. Everyone else joyfully followed suit. Eijiro bent down and unzipped his bag to reveal sunblock, a colorful

beach ball, floaties, and towels for all of them. He started blowing up the beach ball with deep breaths until he was red in the face.

“It is super nice,” Inasa commented merrily. “I see a path up to the cliff where the waterfall is. I always enjoyed cannonballing!”

Shouto laughed from beside him and eagerly agreed. “It has been so long since we let loose.”

Everyone casually stripped down and changed into swimsuits they apparently packed. Of course, the Ashido-Kirishimas had matching ones. They were bright red and pink with ‘Manliness’ stamped on their asses again. Then the agenda for their work out DVD was pushed on the group once more. Katsuki was a single hair away from just purchasing it so they could be quiet.

Katsuki stripped down to his boxers, having not brought a swimsuit. He hadn’t planned on getting in any water when he packed for this assignment, but to hell with it.

Everyone started running off towards the top of the cliff, but Izuku was still hesitantly fingering the hem of his shorts. He was turned away from him, as if waiting for something. Then, Izuku took a deep breath.

Katsuki’s brain went haywire when Izuku dropped his khakis.

“*Panties*?” Katsuki exclaimed automatically.

Izuku startled and turned around with wide eyes. He cupped his crotch protectively, clearly embarrassed beyond belief.

Sitting a little too pretty on Izuku was the frilliest, thinnest pair of pink panties Katsuki had ever seen. They were slightly sheer in the back, giving a full view of Izuku’s freckled ass and it had cute little pink bows adoring the sides.

“*Don’t*—Don’t you dare say a word,” Izuku hissed out. He was glaring deeply with a beet red face. “I didn’t get dressed thinking I was going to take my clothes off today.”

“So, you do this frequently?” Katsuki muttered in disbelief. “I think you’re far more invested in the clothing for this assignment than you’re leading on.”

Izuku blushed deeply. “Stop looking at me you pervert.”

“*Pervert*?” Katsuki exclaimed loudly, offended. “Quit calling me a goddamn pervert when you’re the one wearing women’s underwear—”

“—*So*?!” Izuku snapped, clearly sensitive about the subject. “I-I can wear what I want if I like it. Lace doesn’t have a gender.”

Katsuki worked his jaw, and his morbid curiosity took him to a place he never thought it would. His mind reflected back to all the times they had fought up-close.

Did Izuku wear this type of stuff on all his assignments?

“You got a lot of frilly shit like this, Deku?” Katsuki asked in a low voice, unable to stop himself. He reached out and snapped one of the thin straps on Izuku’s hips with a finger. “Does it make you feel pretty or somethin’?”

Izuku spluttered before storming off.

Katsuki took that as a yes, cute underwear did make Izuku feel pretty.

That fact alone did nothing to help the growing heat against the bottom of his belly. He imagined that since Izuku liked romantic novels, he would probably enjoy being treated like a pillow prince of sorts.

As they walked up the cliff, Izuku’s ass was directly in his face. Katsuki could fucking see *everything*. With each step Izuku took a small ripple from his thighs up to his ass occurred. It made Katsuki bite the inside of his cheek until he tasted iron.

By the time they caught up with the rest of the group, Katsuki was mentally thinking about dead birds to kill his boner.

“Hey, we were wondering where you two w—o-oh!” Inasa’s eyes bulged at the sight of Izuku. He turned his gaze away as if he was a man of respect. “H-Hiroji! Sorry about that! I didn’t realize you two didn’t bring swimsuits.”

“We forgot to pack them,” Katsuki lied easily. “It’s alright though we’ll just change when we get back to the campgrounds.”

Shouto’s, Jirou’s, and Momo’s eyebrows all shot up at Izuku’s frilly underwear. In full contrast, the Ashido-Kirishimas stared and nodded in approval.

“Very manly, Hiroji!” Eijiro said with a grin and a thumbs up. “I like it! I have a pair like that but in red.”

“You’re lucky, Taro,” Mina said with a wink. “Hiroji, those are super cute on you! I sometimes give Eijiro lingerie too. It definitely helps your partner always feel appreciated!”

Izuku laughed awkwardly, still cupping his crotch in embarrassment. Katsuki watched the way his legs pressed together and couldn’t help his eyes from landing on his blushing chest. Katsuki felt himself salivate a bit. Izuku had perfect nipples too.

“Okay! Cannonball time!” Eijiro announced. “Everyone, get in line!”

They all awkwardly shuffled with the lead of the Ashido-Kirishimas’. One by one everyone jumped in with yells and loud splashes.

Jirou did a normal jump holding the beach ball, and Momo gracefully swan dived like a practiced athlete. Eijiro and Mina did a rather impressive, synchronized backflip. Inasa did a cannonball and nearly splashed all the water out the lake while Shouto casually jumped in.

By the time it was their turn, they both stood there staring over the ledge. Or at least Izuku was.

Katsuki's eyes were too busy crawling up and down Izuku's body, drinking in the smooth tanned skin.

The blond hit man was taken back at how the other man had freckles *everywhere*. Freckles were delicately placed on his shoulders, thighs and on his fat ass.

Katsuki bit his lip and groaned.

He detested the way he was so obviously sexually attracted to Izuku. He always knew he was to some degree, a *manageable* degree, but now it felt like he was a helpless object being sucked into Izuku's ass's gravitational pull.

He had to snap himself out of it.

Considering fucking a stranger on an assignment was one thing but contemplating fucking the man Aizawa told him to kill was another. Maybe he could remind himself that Izuku was an annoying little shit and not a fuckable, flexible, squeezable—*no*. Ugh. Goddamnit, *no*. Yeah. He needed to shake himself out of it pronto.

Which is why he reverted straight back to being an asshole.

He walked up behind Izuku, placed his hands on both sides of his shoulders and smirked fiendishly down at him. Izuku glanced up, baffled at the sudden contact.

"Remember when you asked if I would push you overboard yesterday?" Katsuki asked with a glint in his eye.

Izuku went still and narrowed his eyes into dangerous slits. "You wouldn't dare."

"Oh. I *would*."

Izuku protested immediately and began thrashing. He tried to snatch himself out of the tight grasp, but Katsuki was the stronger one between the two.

The blond gleefully shoved Izuku over the edge of the cliff and Izuku screamed as he went tumbling down. Katsuki let out a sharp laugh watching Izuku fall but shrieked in surprise when a hand grabbed onto his ankle and dragged him down too.

They went ungracefully falling into the lake below together with a giant splash.

Katsuki's nostrils burned with the blunt feeling of water slamming into him. The invading liquid rushed into his nose, mouth, and ears. He choked ungracefully and had to forcefully close his eyes as he was dunked further under water by the heavy pull of gravity. He immediately began kicking to swim and gasped for air when he broke the surface.

Izuku came up shortly after and pressed the heel of his palms into his eyes. The freckled hitman groaned loudly and shook his head. Izuku glowered and immediately splashed water at him.

"Why did you *push* me?!"

Katsuki yelped and splashed water back, glare in full force.

“Why the hell did you drag me down?!”

Izuku puffed his cheeks out and splashed back again, angry. Katsuki returned the gesture, refusing to be the last to get splashed. Red and green eyes clashed in the moment, and they went on like this for a while. It wasn’t until it dawned on both men how ridiculous they were being, much less how ridiculous they *looked*, that they stopped. They stifled laughs, staring at the other’s soaking wet hair in the sunlight.

“—Ahem.”

Both hitmen froze and turned their gaze to their party. Everyone was wading in the water looking at them unsettled.

Shit. Katsuki forgot they were in front of people...*yet again*.

Momo wearily glanced between them before swimming forward. “A-Are you two good?” She asked.

“Oh yeah! We’re fine!” Izuku said quickly with a forced grin. “Ha. Just playful shenanigans.”

Izuku placed his arms around his shoulders lovingly with a faux smile. He leaned in fully to the large body as if they weren’t just having a water fight like two kids in a pool. Katsuki reluctantly followed suit and wrapped his arms around Izuku’s back and held him tightly. He reminded himself of affection, touches and actions.

He leaned down and gave Izuku a cliche kiss on the forehead, ignoring how wide green eyes went.

“This is just how we get along,” Katsuki reassured when Momo was giving him that ‘are you sure you’re not an abusive husband?’ stare. “We think it’s funny to mess with each other.”

“Hey, it’s chill man,” Eijiro said as he began floating. “Every couple expresses themselves differently!”

“Yeah! We do!” Izuku said with a fake smile as bright as the sun. “L-Let’s just have some fun! Diving was great!”

Everyone shrugged it off, seemingly accepting their dysfunction. It seemed like Eijiro, and Mina accepted that they were a disaster, and Shouto and Inasa squinted—but let it go. Out of everyone, Momo seemed to be the most concerned. However, when Jirou threw the beach ball to her, the black-haired therapist let it go.

They began bumping the beach ball in the air and everyone started relaxing fully.

☽ ☽ ☽

They spent most of the day by the lake.

Everyone was having leisure fun. Jirou was playing music while Momo and Mina exchanged hair care routines. Inasa and Eijiro showed off some dives and Shouto relaxed on the side where all their clothes were. It was enjoyable and slowly they started melding together better as a group.

The diving incident brought him and Izuku back to their usual sardonic banter. Katsuki would sneer anytime Izuku commented on his wild spikes, and he would reply back something along the lines that Izuku had too many freckles. While they were still slightly blushing at each other, they were exchanging witty lines back and forth whenever something occurred.

By the time dusk filled the atmosphere, Katsuki found himself staring up at the sky of canopies and sun. He was free floating in the water with Izuku while everyone else was off to the side talking. He had floated out to the middle of the lake area by himself originally, but then Izuku swam up towards him under the excuse of 'spending time with his husband.'

Then Izuku started floating too so they basked there in the evening sun, wordlessly side by side. The pair quietly listened to the sounds of the forest. Katsuki turned to Izuku, seeing him look tranquil as well pulled at a heart string in his chest. He cleared his throat.

"Uh, sorry about pushing you off a cliff," Katsuki muttered. "Sometimes I get the urge to be a dick and I can't really stop it."

"It's okay," Izuku muttered back. "Sorry for dragging you off with me. You deserved it though."

"Yeah, I really fucking did."

They both lightly laughed as they basked in the setting sun.

Katsuki returned his gaze forward, to stare up at the orange sky that was hiding behind the thick covering of treetops. The visual struck him in a peculiar way as he listened to the sound of all the animals and insects in a symphony together. When a set of birds flew from one tree to another, Katsuki realized that he hadn't worried about anything for most of the day.

The underlying danger of Moore had faded to the back of his mind. He knew he had to find a way to call Aizawa—but when he looked at Izuku who had his eyes closed, floating peacefully in the water, he felt the need to tune out the rest of the world too.

Katsuki took a deep breath and closed his eyes, allowing himself to unwind and focus on the feeling of the gentle water hugging his skin.

"Do you hear that?" Izuku asked in a tiny whisper.

"Hear what?"

"The ryukyu robins. They're singing to each other."

Katsuki listened closer, focusing only on the birds. He heard some level of shuffling and ruffling but tuned it out to really hear what Izuku highlighted. Then when he narrowed in, he heard light chirps and the call of robins spinning all around them.

Katsuki smiled lightly to himself.

“Y’know. This is probably the most relaxed I’ve been in a while,” Katsuki admitted into the silence.

“Me too. It feels sad to admit this out loud, but this really is the closest thing to a vacation I’ve gotten.”

“It’s not sad,” Katsuki corrected. “It’s the same for me, I might fuck with you but don’t feel bad about enjoying this.”

“Thank you,” Izuku whispered. “I’m glad you understand.”

They floated there for a while, until Katsuki turned his head to gaze at the quiet man next to him. He was surprised to see forest green eyes staring back at him already, giving him a soft gaze. Katsuki was about to return the gesture, feeling oddly compelled to but stopped when his focus shifted past Izuku to the edge of the lake.

He frowned.

“Wait,” Katsuki said suddenly. He shifted his body from floating to swimming in place. “Where the hell did everyone go?”

Izuku frowned too. The green-eyed man turned his body in the water as well to gaze towards where they last left everyone. And just like Katsuki said, they were all gone. They both swam towards the edge of the lake in confusion only to find their hiking bags and a small note sitting there for them.

Think of this as free couples’ therapy!

—Signed, Everyone.

Katsuki flipped over the small note in his hand unhappily. He searched for more or an explanation but found nothing but a tiny little heart drawn in black ink.

“Did they really fucking leave us alone to *bond*?” He hissed in disbelief. “They can’t be serious…”

Well, he guessed it was no real question. He and Izuku were always making a scene to get this fake dating thing down. Everyone probably thought they had marital issues stacked higher than Mount Everest—but to go this far?

“K-Katsuki—where’s our clothes?” Izuku’s shaky voice whispered.

Everything in Katsuki’s mind came to a screeching halt. He frantically looked around for their pile of clothes because there was absolutely no fucking way those extras did that. But when he saw the very empty rock where they had left their garments—his heart sunk.

“I’m going to murder them,” Katsuki hissed, crumbling up the note in his fist. “I’m going to actually fucking murder them. Those goddamn *imbeciles*.”

He looked down at his soaking wet boxers and groaned. Then, with mild hesitation, he glanced out the corner of his eye towards Izuku. The blushing freckled man was bashfully cupping his goddamn crotch in horror.

“C’mon,” Katsuki said impatiently as he grabbed his hiking bag. “Let’s get back to the damn campsite.”

Izuku nodded furiously, face already painted pink. Katsuki strapped his bag to his bare back while Izuku put it over his front, loosening the straps to modestly cover himself. Katsuki muttered a prayer to himself to give him the strength not to blow a blood vessel.

☽ ☽ ☽

Turns out, hiking barefoot in a subtropical forest even for two hitmen was a fucking task.

Every stick, twig, and rock that dug into his foot brought Katsuki closer to committing six counts of homicide. Sure, him and Izuku were fucking dysfunctional, and they casually threw each other a cliff and almost got into another fight but they *didn’t*. They got past it!

This was probably Momo’s idea, Katsuki bitterly thought to himself as they went up a particularly steep incline. *She’s the therapist. She’s been up in our goddamn business since the aerobics class.*

It was dark now, and in this type of dense forest, Katsuki was straining to see. The thick canopy above them was blocking out most of the white moonlight, only giving way to a couple of spots. Which didn’t help jack shit. They had hiked at least an hour or so away from the lake on foot. Every shrub and tree was beginning to look the same in the darkness and it was difficult to distinguish.

He stared up at the sky every now and then when he could smell the ting of incoming rain—that was *not* forecasted.

“We need to hurry,” Izuku said, slightly on edge. “It smells like a storm is coming soon—and I don’t think we can keep going on the dirt path when it’s wet like this. We’ll fall off.”

Katsuki grunted in response, agreeing.

As they continued, it felt like the signs were off. Like a shifting maze made of trees and foliage and it was fucking with his senses. He knew the people in their group probably thought of this as a harmless prank. They probably figured it would help spark something between him and Izuku while they were practically nude—but he was livid.

Katsuki looked behind him in the dark to Izuku who winced when he stepped on another rock. The freckled hitman yelped in pain and stumbled a bit. He slid his foot back on the unstable dirt but both red and green eyes went wide when Izuku completely lost his balance. He started falling backwards—right off the ledge of the incline.

Before he could think, Katsuki’s body moved on its own.

His arm shot out and grabbed Izuku by the straps on his hiking backpack, and he dug his heels into the ground to work against gravity. With all his strength he snapped Izuku back upwards and steadied him from falling off the ledge.

“A-Ah, thank you,” Izuku muttered when Katsuki hoisted him back upwards.

“Fucking watch your step,” Katsuki hissed. He let go of Izuku and began climbing again. “If you break your ankle being a klutz, I am *not* taking care of you.”

“I wouldn’t want you to take care of me anyways,” Izuku countered back with a mumble. “You probably have a skewed version of care.”

Katsuki shook his head as they continued onwards. But then he heard something rustle from on top of the incline and stopped. He held his arm out for Izuku to halt when the rustling became clearer.

Then a small bead of water hit Katsuki’s nose. He glanced up in dread when several more trickled down. Then it quickly became a pattern and a light sprinkle. The rustling happened again and then stopped. They both stilled, quiet in place as the rain began to come down.

After two beats of silence, Katsuki started moving again. He didn’t want to get caught in a storm on a steep incline and he knew Izuku had no desire to either.

They continued walking with no incidents until they came to a fork in the path. The sign that was there pointed to ‘Dead End’ in the path to the right and ‘Campsite’ to the one on the left. Katsuki probed his tongue against his cheek when something felt off about it.

They veered left and slowly the path started progressively turning into something much rougher and unkept. After about a minute in, it was clear as day to Katsuki that this was the path least taken—not back to the campsite.

More rustling and they both froze in the pitch blackness.

Chilling goosebumps raked up and down Katsuki’s skin.

“We should turn around,” Izuku whispered seriously. His voice hardened with a sharp edge. “I think someone is switching the signs—”

It happened in a split second.

Katsuki barely caught the visual of a large man that sprung out from the darkness in front of him. The man was wearing all black, a ski-mask and wielding a deadly dagger in one hand and a gun with a silencer attached in the other.

Instantly, the man used his knife and went straight for Katsuki’s jugular.

Pushing through the sharp pain on his feet from the unsteady ground, Katsuki promptly maneuvered backwards. The tip of the deadly blade missed, grazing him by a hair.

With quick-thinking instincts, Katsuki swiftly slung his hiking bag to block the next deadly blow that went for his throat. The sharp weapon pierced through his backpack and without hesitation, Katsuki spun his bag to disarm the man of his knife. He grunted loudly as he turned to land a powerful kick in the man's gut, causing him to double over.

The man hissed and drew his gun up, aiming square for Katsuki's head. However, before he could pull the trigger, Izuku worked rapidly like deadly lightning. He dropped his bag and grabbed the gun in the man's other hand. With precision he twisted the attacker's wrist until he screamed out in pain and dropped the weapon.

The attacker tried to quickly grab for Izuku, but the freckled hitman kicked his legs up from underneath him and dropped him in a second.

Katsuki dropped his bag that still had the knife lodged inside it. He took the opportunity to quickly wrap his arm around the man's neck from behind as he struggled back upwards.

The man tried to fight him off, but he was stronger. Katsuki used his body weight to gain control and squeezed his arm tightly around the thin throat until the man began taking desperate gulps for oxygen. Gasps filled the night air as the man squirmed and groaned. Katsuki gritted his teeth as he carefully tightened his hold on the attacker. They both dropped to their knees and Katsuki then pinned him on the ground underneath his overpowering weight.

The rain fell heavier, and the air shifted.

The dark suddenly felt more rigid and ominous as both he and Izuku glanced around into the pitch blackness, waiting for more assailants. Izuku drew his fang shaped dagger from his bag and searched around the area from which the man came. Green eyes were no longer sweet, but deadly and alert. The freckled hitman took an offensive stance, ready to strike at the nearest level of movement.

They waited in silence, the pitter patter of pouring rain operating like an unnerving metronome.

The pulsing of adrenaline in Katsuki's veins shifted him out of his once leisure-like mindset into cold, calculating solemnity. He watched Izuku peer into bushes, check behind all the trees and walk down the rest of the pathway. The green-eyed hitman left to scout the rest of the trail as they stayed tethered to vigilance.

But when Izuku returned, he shook his head and lowered his weapon.

"There's no one else," Izuku whispered into the rain. "He came alone."

Katsuki then turned his attention to the man in his grasp who went still.

Scarlet eyes laid sights on the attacker in the ski mask, and then shifted to the sharp knife that was still lodged into his backpack. Immediately, his deadly training kicked in. That not so kind, darker part of his spirit gripped him by his spine, taking over. Katsuki forced all

empathy to drain from his body as the attacker tried to struggle against him. Katsuki violently shook the man in his grasp as a warning.

“Do you work for Moore?” Katsuki hissed menacingly.

The man didn’t answer and only glared up at them, as if he took a blood oath to stay quiet.

Izuku then stepped forward and placed down his hiking bag. He knelt with them to eye level of the man before swiping off his ski-mask.

Both Izuku and Katsuki were only partially surprised to recognize the man as the bartender from the lounge. Izuku pursed his lips and Katsuki felt it in his gut too: this confirmed their unspoken suspicions.

The freckled hitman searched the attacker’s deep pockets until he pulled out two items. The first was a syringe filled with a clear substance and the other was a picture of Katsuki and Izuku on the White Dove. It was a photograph of them smiling at each other, dancing hand in hand wearing their leis.

He flipped the small photograph, and on the back, it read: *Lean male/green eyes. Don’t use excessive force or bruise skin. Capture in woods. Spouse is an aggressive brute. Separate from spouse or kill if unable to separate.*

“Ah, he was my designated kidnapper,” Izuku said curiously.

Katsuki watched how Izuku uncapped the syringe and pushed the bottom slightly until a small droplet formed at the end of the needle. He used his index finger to swipe it and put it at the tip of his tongue. Izuku made a serious face before cutting his eye at the man.

“And this is ketamine.” Izuku sighed before standing up straight. “I guess they were going for the lovers lost in the woods angle.”

“What do we do with him?” Katsuki said seriously. The man’s brown eyes glanced between him and Izuku as he stayed pinned on the ground. “If I get a call from my supervisor, and he tells me to stay, I can’t leave until we finish off Moore.”

“Me either,” Izuku said in a pensive tone. He tilted his head at the failed kidnapper. “If you can, knock him out but don’t crush his windpipe. We don’t want it to look like he was strangled. It has to seem like we never encountered him.”

Katsuki took the hint at what that meant.

The man started screaming but couldn’t get a word past his throat as he began clawing at Katsuki’s bicep in the pouring rain. Katsuki closed his eyes as he pushed down all his emotions in the same manner he always did for this part of the job. The fingernails dug into his skin, burning, and leaving multiple scratch marks. Blood was drawn, leaving behind traces of desperation as Katsuki’s heart went numb.

The man in his grasp struggled helplessly until he fell limp.

Katsuki then unlocked him from the sleeper hold and checked his pulse. Still beating. Katsuki cut his eyes up to Izuku who was glancing down, green eyes sharp and calculating.

“Moore is going to wonder why his lackey was unsuccessful,” Izuku said slowly. The rain from up above started pouring harder onto them. “What would be an inconspicuous set up?”

“Him slipping and falling off the side of a cliff in a rainstorm is a plausible scenario,” Katsuki said as he let out a deep exhale. He pointed to the back of the man’s neck with two fingers. “We could quarter break his cervical spine. It’ll look like he slipped, fell and hit his head bluntly.”

Izuku nodded distantly. “Yeah. That works.”

The green-eyed man carefully cleaned his prints from the photograph and syringe with the rain droplets before sliding them back into the man’s pockets. Katsuki walked over to the knife and gun and did the same, rearming the man as if he never drew his weapons. He carefully cleaned under the man’s nails until they were spotless.

After they finished making sure they were invisible, Katsuki carefully positioned himself over the limp body and squatted. He grabbed the man’s head in his hands with careful technique but didn’t move right away.

Him and Izuku exchanged stares, acknowledging the moment.

Katsuki snapped the man’s neck precisely.

☽ ☽ ☽

The rain felt different now as they trudged on. Before, it felt foreboding. Like a thin veil that hid away the lurking danger in the forest. Now it felt heavy like the rain at a funeral, as though the sky was the only being weeping for the loss of life.

Neither he nor Izuku spoke in the silent rhythm of the pouring rain. In an odd way, he was familiar with this side of the other hitman. The quiet, calculating side that was in deep thought. Usually, he was on the other side of Izuku’s lethality, so it didn't feel wrong, but it didn’t feel all the way right either.

Deep down, Katsuki understood it was part of their jobs to tie up loose ends.

But there was something about it that left a residue feeling over his palms every time he had a higher kill count than intended for an assignment. It was beginning to accumulate now, stacking high on the pads of his fingers.

They staged the scene to look as though the man simply stumbled and fell over the incline in the pouring rain. Which was plausible considering he and Izuku were struggling not to do that now. Without their boots, the dirt floor of the forest was impossible to climb, and the rain made visibility low.

It wasn’t until they found a small nook embedded into the side of a cliff that they decided to give up.

Katsuki sighed in relief and leaned against the wall of the tiny cave. It was barely a cave, more of a slight indentation but it worked for two people. He felt icky. His body was drenched, hair wet and flat against his forehead.

His backpack was heavy with water weight as he threw it to the ground resentfully. He looked at Izuku who tiredly dropped his backpack too, not caring anymore about his modesty in the skimpy underwear. Katsuki took off his boxers without shame and Izuku averted his eyes. The blond sighed as he wrung out the rainwater in the boxers before sliding them back on.

“I don’t think the storm is going to stop soon,” Izuku pointed out. He looked out past the thin veil of pouring water dripping in front of the mouth of the concave. “I’m sure the group meant it in humor since it wasn’t forecasted to rain—but this isn’t all that fun.”

“Yeah, they’re fucking idiots.” Katsuki grunted. “I guess we’ll camp here until it breaks.”

Izuku nodded in agreement as he sat down on the ground. He curled his legs into his chest with a far-off look into the rain. Katsuki sat across from him, legs stretched out and long enough to hit the other side of the small concave. They both looked up at the dark atmosphere and noticed the lack of beautiful birds singing.

Katsuki took a moment to assess Izuku. The freckled hitman looked downright exhausted—and nearly as though something else was bothering him. Katsuki watched how Izuku brought a hand up to his clavicle and dragged it over the bare skin where the number ‘217’ was tattooed. The band aid covering it was lost to the heavy rain.

“Are you feeling okay?” Katsuki asked, eyeing him carefully. “You tasted that ketamine earlier. You’re not woozy, are you?”

“Oh, I have a tolerance against it,” Izuku explained distantly. “Don’t worry about me.”

Katsuki raised his eyebrows but decided it made fucking sense. “Moore is going to try to kidnap you again I’m sure,” he decided to change the subject to what they should focus on. “How should we navigate that?”

“We could use it to our advantage.” Izuku grew quiet as he thought deeply about their next move. “It would be easy to get him alone since he has his sights set on me. We can confirm he thinks we’re normal citizens too, since he only sent one heavy bodied assailant as though it would be enough. Let’s possibly take him up on that drink offer. With the two of us, we’ll overpower him and his assistant with no issue.”

“True.” Katsuki clicked his tongue. “Poor bastard chose the wrong vacation goers.”

There was a moment of silence.

“Do you...Do you feel anything when you do it?” Izuku asked, barely above a whisper.

Luminescent green eyes gazed at him in the dark.

Any other time, Katsuki would've deflected the question and acted as though he was the stone-cold killer he used to be in his early days. But this time he didn't. There was a tender look of vulnerability in Izuku's endless green eyes that lowered his defenses.

"Most days I don't," Katsuki answered honestly. He shifted slightly. "But more recently—yeah. I do."

"I feel a little bit too," Izuku admitted, making Katsuki feel a bit more human. "I try my best not to, like I was trained. But it's something about when the moment comes to finish—the inkling of the subconscious I try to drown speaks out."

"A mark is a mark," Katsuki said quietly. "Subconscious or not, we have a job to do. Loose ends aren't good. *Especially* ones that are trying to traffic you."

Izuku let out a dry laugh, it was slightly sarcastic. "Yeah, I guess not."

Katsuki looked curiously at the man in front of him. A question that's been forming since he started to get to know Izuku tumbled out of his mouth.

"Why do you do this job?" Katsuki asked.

He considered all the things about Izuku. He was shy. Timid for the most part. Coupled with that, he was a hopeless romantic who binged on books and films. Izuku was bizarrely patient and alright with teaching him how to pretend to be in love. It didn't add up to him.

"I do it to survive," Izuku said distantly. His green eyes looked away, shielding his emotions. "And you?"

"Money," Katsuki said with a shrug. "I guess that's the same thing. Survival."

He took the hint from Izuku's tone of voice that said to back off. But unfortunately, that only watered the budding seed of curiosity he had growing inside of him.

He watched how Izuku dug into his bag and checked his phone once more, no signal once again showing. The green-eyed man carefully placed his fang shaped knife on the ground next to them. Katsuki did the same—in case there truly was more than one kidnapper out there looking for them.

Katsuki leaned his head back and leisurely listened to the sound of the pouring rain.

Hours passed by in casual conversation with Izuku, and Katsuki found himself realizing they shared more ground than he thought.

They had the same favorite classical music selections. He learned Izuku's favorite food was katsudon. Izuku liked the fact he enjoyed spicy meals. Katsuki talked about his distant wish to live in the countryside and Izuku shared about his violin lessons. Which, in a strange way, captivated Katsuki. He always wanted to take music lessons but never had the leeway.

When sleep finally invaded their bodies, Katsuki tried his best to get comfortable in the tight, damp space.

He leaned his head against his hiking backpack and tried to close his eyes. Izuku did the same on the opposite side of the cave. But due to the proximity, Katsuki felt the small tremors and shivers that raked through Izuku's body.

Katsuki peeked one eye open and could see Izuku huddled in on himself for warmth but was greatly failing. His small body was shivering with the gusts of the incoming winds. Crimson eyes flickered down to the thin piece of clothing barely covering Izuku's private parts and the way his hands were still cupping his crotch.

He felt sorry for him to an extent.

"Are you cold?" Katsuki asked.

Izuku shook his head and blushed. "No."

"But you're shivering."

"It's alright. I run cold."

Katsuki sucked at his teeth as he thought about it. He felt slightly compelled by an unknown force as his thoughts tousled around. He debated heavily. Close contact with Deku—it was something he was fully against, or at least he thought was. His mind wandered back to the car ride over here and suddenly he didn't feel so against it anymore.

Never in a million years would he have thought about this a week ago. *Never*. But he shifted himself to his side, opening a clearing that was perfectly Izuku-sized. He gestured with his hand 'come here'.

"Lucky for you, I run hot."

Izuku's eyes went wide, and he looked at Katsuki as though he had gone mad.

"Y'know, it won't be weird in this situation," Katsuki tried to reason. More so for himself than Izuku. "It's chilly, wet and we're in a dark forest. If you want, we can—"

"—I-It's okay!" Izuku stuttered. His face burned. "I-I'll be fine."

"C'mon. Get your stubborn ass over here." Katsuki impatiently waved his hand. "I told you already I'm not taking care of you. That *includes* if you catch a cold."

Katsuki liked the way Izuku grew a bit timid. It fed into a very specific side of him that devoured the pink blush racing down that freckled neck. All those loud, conflicting emotions inside of him wrestled again when Izuku finally conceded. The green-eyed hitman nodded his head bashfully, still not meeting his gaze.

He removed his hand from his crotch and Katsuki felt his nostrils flare and his stomach knot with heat.

Izuku's panties had a pouch fitted for his cock and other equipment. So they technically *weren't* women's underwear. Red eyes blinked twice at the sight and the tiny pink bow on top

of the pouch. Izuku crawled towards him and then froze.

Viridian eyes regarded him, unsure. The heat from the proximity was nearly palatable. Katsuki swallowed as he forced his eyes away from Izuku's crotch.

"Which way should I, uh, face?" Izuku muttered.

"Turn around," Katsuki said simply.

He didn't want to say too much else, unable to trust his voice as all the heat started to gradually rise.

Izuku nodded quickly, averting his eyes. He turned around and Katsuki held his breath for a moment as he pushed against him.

The blond swallowed when his mouth started to salivate at the newfound body heat. Izuku was even softer without clothes, and the skin-on-skin contact lit his nerve endings with torridness. He tried to tell himself it was a natural body reaction as Izuku snuggled back against him, fitting perfectly as a little spoon.

Katsuki hesitantly positioned his arms and wrapped tight. He placed his head next to Izuku's on his slightly damp hiking bag. Gradually, the shaking from the smaller body within his arms slowly stopped. After a few minutes he heard Izuku give a small breath of relief. From his angle, he could see Izuku close his eyes.

"Better?" Katsuki asked in a low voice.

Izuku nodded and pushed back against him slightly. "Better. Thank you."

The motion sent a low roll of heat waves through Katsuki. He knew Izuku was only attempting to get closer for body warmth, but it was in its own way intimate. Katsuki shifted and drew Izuku in closer, pressing against him tightly. Their ankles knocked together until their legs intertwined and the closeness sparked a warmth in the air that was thicker than the car ride up.

Katsuki pondered their proximity.

Never in this lifetime would he have thought about Deku in this way, but his conflicting thoughts were beginning to shift balance towards the darker side of his thoughts. Egged on by his curiosity melting with heat, he shifted slightly to peer over at the frilly underwear in a different light. The warmth at the bottom of his core spiked in temperature.

"By the way, I think your panties are cute," he rasped in Izuku's ear.

Izuku's eyes snapped open, and the other man started to squirm against him again.

"S-Shut up. Y-You said you wouldn't make it weird—"

"—I mean it honestly," Katsuki said, tightening his hold to stop Izuku from squirming away. "They're pretty on you."

Izuku went still and he turned his head. In the motion, their noses brushed and suddenly they were both aware of just how close they were. Katsuki could feel the other man's breath on his lips as they stared at each other in silence for a while.

"You probably like it, don't you?" Katsuki whispered in a gruff voice, fully curious to what makes Izuku tick. He lifted his head to look down at where Izuku was squirming ever so slightly. His plush thighs were pressing together, and his ankles were locking around Katsuki's. "Feelin' all delicate like that in contrast to what we got to do all the time. Makes you feel *soft*."

There was a heavy silence.

Unspoken tension swelled between them as all of Katsuki's rational thoughts were slowly drowning in a sea of green. Viridian eyes flickered down to Katsuki's lips while scarlet eyes greedily drank in the sight of Izuku's body.

There was a shift as they stared at each other.

"G-Goodnight, Katsuki," Izuku whispered.

He broke the moment and faced forward again.

Katsuki observed how Izuku closed his eyes and forced them to stay closed. The erratic heart inside of Izuku's chest cavity was so clear and the nervousness in the air was tangible. But above all, Katsuki felt his erratic heart too. He closed his eyes as well and nuzzled into the soft neck.

"Goodnight, Izuku."

☽ ☽ ☽

"Guys! I found them! They're over here!"

Mina's shrill voice was like a blasting alarm. Katsuki groaned as he blinked his eyes open unwillingly. The sound of what felt like a stampede of footsteps rushed towards them. It was a blur of colors that screamed the rainbow to Katsuki. Pink. Red. Red and white and purple.

He grumbled. Unimpressed scarlet eyes stared up at their paradise crew who were staring down at them like they found the treasure to Atlantis. Katsuki shifted on his forearms and lifted. There was a heavy weight around his shoulders that made him peer down.

There, he found Izuku's arms lazily wrapped around his neck. The smaller man was snuggly tucked underneath him, fitting perfectly as if Katsuki was a warm blanket. Their legs were tangled and Izuku's hands were woven into his hair.

"Oh, my goodness, we're so, *so* sorry!" Mina rushed and apologized. She quickly took out blankets and heating pads. "W-We didn't know it was going to rain and we tried to go back for you, but the signs were all weird last night! The winds must've blown them all wrong!"

“Are you guys alright?” Shouto asked wearily. “We thought you two being naked in the woods might be something you’d be into, but we didn’t anticipate that storm.”

“We’re fine. No thanks to you dipshits,” Katsuki griped. “Thanks for fucking leaving us stranded.”

Izuku, still heavy with sleep and groggy, groaned. His eyes remained shut as he tightened his hold on Katsuki’s neck and massaged his hands through blond spikes. Katsuki raised a brow as Izuku softly yawned and lifted his hips until their pelvises intimately pressed together.

Then, mid-yawn, Izuku’s eyes gradually blinked open.

They made eye contact for a moment and Izuku immediately froze, sobering quickly. Rose colored blushed ran down Izuku’s freckled throat, and Katsuki found that he enjoyed it. Izuku quickly retreated his arms, lowered his hips, and cleared his throat.

“Ah. G-Good morning, everyone,” Izuku said sheepishly with a smile. He scratched behind his head. “Nice to see you’re all safe from the storm.”

“We’re so sorry again, we’ll have to make it up to you,” Momo said with a sincere apology.

“Let's just get back to that stupid campsite,” Katsuki muttered. “I’m starving.”

He stood up and stretched. He graciously took one of the blankets from Momo, happy to have some layers of clothes. But as he was about to wrap the blanket around him, Jirou made a sharp gasp.

“Oh my. I see you two were up to no good last night,” Jirou said with a hint of surprise.

Both Izuku and Katsuki froze, looking at her both slightly nervous and confused.

“Wh-What?” Izuku probed, looking at her with cautious eyes. “Why would you think that?”

Jirou smiled and pointed to the scratch marks on Katsuki’s arm with a knowing glint in her eye. “It seems like the impromptu couples’ therapy worked a little bit.”

Both of them looked at the bloodied nail marks on Katsuki’s bicep. It appeared as though an animal—or human had run their nails down his arm in either the heat of passion or the coldness of death.

Katsuki and Izuku dryly laughed as they all started to head back to the campsite.

☽ ☽ ☽

They got back to the campsite with ease. Katsuki noted how some of the signs had been switched to the opposite of what they were last night, meaning this forest was a death and kidnapping trap for Moore. He wondered what other shit was lurking in its depths at night. There were probably even booty traps ready to snatch the nearest unsuspecting pair of lovers.

Upon arrival, Katsuki immediately scarfed down all the food he could see in sight. His hunger was threatening to chew through his stomach. He'd never been more thankful for graham crackers in his life. Izuku bolted straight for the tent, immediately getting dressed in a pair of pink shorts and a white t-shirt. Katsuki got dressed in his usual black gear.

When they fully reset, the group seemed excited to go about their day.

"Alrighty! Camping day round two!" Eijiro shouted enthusiastically. "Who's ready for another awesome day!"

"I am. If you guys don't leave us stranded again," Katsuki mumbled.

This time, Izuku didn't correct his rude comment.

It made him smirk thinking about how the usually polite man agreed with him.

But when he looked down at his faux husband, Izuku glanced up and met his eyes. There was an underlying shyness behind them now. Izuku pushed his hands in his shorts pockets and followed the group to their next destination.

☽ ☽ ☽

They found themselves deciding on kayaking in the large river with everyone.

They went to the more citizen-friendly part of the forest and rented out several tandem kayaks. It was relaxing, peaceful, and allowed them all to get a spacious view of the forest.

On the way here, Izuku slyly mentioned wanting to stick together and possibly not going that deep into the forest. Mainly because they didn't want to have to have too many bodies stacked and trip Moore's suspicions. One clumsy failed kidnapper was an easy spin, but two would without a doubt make any professional human trafficker raise an eyebrow.

Everyone eagerly agreed, still feeling some guilt for leaving them butt ass naked in the wilderness. They all felt remorseful, but in a strange way it worked out for him and Izuku. Everyone in their Paradise Crew believed they had rough sex in that cave last night. Which cleared up any doubts of them being a couple for Inasa and Shouto. The two cops made a joke about how they must've had a thing for doing it in the woods.

So, they were officially a dysfunctional couple with a public sex kink.

Not *exactly* what Katsuki had in mind for their cover image, but he'd take it.

They still had no cell signal, but once again Katsuki found himself uncaring. He kept his eyes peeled for any more wanna-be-kidnappers but with the overt buddy system Izuku enforced, there was no issue.

They rowed out into the open river in the bright sun, admiring the passing visuals.

Large trees towered over them, like watchful guardians. The reflections of the forest in the clear water made the river appear as if there was an upside-down forest they were paddling

over. Every now and then there were hints of white, purple, and pink delicate flowers blooming up from the earth. They were still heavy with last night's rain, slightly bowed as if greeting them as they rowed past.

What Katsuki liked most was the melody of the birds above them.

The tune relaxed him back into that leisure state of mind. He was rowing in the back while Izuku was facing him, rowing in the front. Viridian doe eyes were starstruck in awe at the captivating landscape encapsulating them. In Katsuki's humble opinion, Izuku's eyes somehow absorbed the hues around them to become an even deeper shade of green.

However, despite the relaxed setting, Izuku seemed more quiet than usual.

Maybe it was the combination of the fact that his little pantie-wearing secret was exposed, or possibly the bare back cuddling. Or maybe it was a combination of a lot of unspoken things.

Whichever the reason, Katsuki wasn't quite sure he liked the silence.

So, he cleared his throat and probed at the one subject he knew Izuku would be gun-ho to discuss.

"What's the next lesson on how to pretend to be in love, nerd?" Katsuki said as they paddled a healthy amount of space behind the group, out of earshot. "We still gotta make it through the next five days."

"O-Oh, right." Izuku looked at him with a gentle smile. They slowed down on rowing a bit and settled into the calmness. "I was, uh, thinking we could work on faking compliments. Lovers tend to say things they like about each other. Like their hair or their smile. Or in general what they find nice about the other person."

"Basically, stating out loud why they fell in love with them?"

"Yeah!" Izuku exclaimed, happy that Katsuki seemed to be catching on. "You could think of it like that. Why don't you give it a shot? Attempt to compliment me."

"I liked your little panties yesterday," Katsuki teased with an arrogant smirk. He flexed an eyebrow at Izuku while looking down at his shorts. "Got another pair of those on?"

"N-Not like that." Izuku blushed deeply, glared at him, and closed his legs. "Something non-suggestive that you can say in front of other people. Like an example would be, someone mentions that your joke was hilarious. I then would laugh, agree and say you're always funny and make me laugh all the time."

Katsuki's smirk widened. "You think I'm funny?"

"Focus."

"Alright, alright," the blond huffed unhappily. He looked up at the trees, trying to figure out something about Izuku he liked. He stared around at the forest, and it felt like a small piece of

his distant memory compelled him. Green. He liked green. “I like your eyes. They look like this forest and my favorite color.”

“O-Okay, maybe something not a physical attribute,” Izuku muttered with a blush and gently rowed. “Try something about my personality.”

“There’s not a single thing about your personality I like.”

“C’mon…”

“Alright, fine.” Katsuki grumbled and slouched a bit with a frown. “It’s going to be hard complimenting the man who shot me when we first met.”

“Just *try*.”

He thought hard about it as he steadily rowed down the river. He tried to see past Izuku’s little shit of an aura. What did he like about Izuku that *wasn’t* his looks? He liked that he threw a blade well. Fucker had perfect aim with a dagger. He also had good common sense on how to stage a homicide without raising alarms. But those were all things he probably shouldn’t mention.

“I like that you’re patient,” Katsuki eventually came to. It was a bit vulnerable, but he was finding he was like that more and more with Izuku. It was easy to be honest with him for an unknown reason. “Not too many people are patient with me, and I uh, appreciate it.”

“There we go. I almost believed that. Good job!” Izuku smiled happily at him as if he was a kid who got his lines right for a play. “Now just remember to say that around people.”

Katsuki blinked, not expecting Izuku to think it was fake. He had forgotten for a moment that what he said didn’t have to be *true*. For an odd reason, Izuku not knowing he meant it earnestly caused disharmony in his chest.

“Right. Yeah.” Katsuki nodded emptily as they continued down their leisure path. “I’ll make sure to pretend to compliment you in front of everyone.”

☽ ☽ ☽

Nightfall came with no incidents. Katsuki was both happy to be leaving this forest of doom, but reluctant that he had to go back to the hotel. It was odd, getting a vacation within a vacation where he was detached from everything—having fun.

And it was even more odd that he was having fun with Izuku.

Throughout the day he remembered to hold his hand, casually kiss his forehead, and compliment him on something. At first, he told himself he should just make shit up to prevent that nails on the chalkboard feeling inside of him. However, faking the goddamn compliments caused even *more* dissonance. So Katsuki settled for real shit he found that he liked about Izuku.

“Yeah, that’s my Darling. He’s really quick on his toes,” he said when they went hiking again.

“Hiroji is smart,” he said when Izuku successfully identified a poisonous plant and prevented Jirou from walking into it. “Biggest nerd I know.”

“He’s always had a kind personality,” Katsuki said when Shouto asked more about them.

It was both surprising and natural how easy it flowed. It shocked Katsuki a bit, and it seemed to have shocked Izuku too. But the man easily swayed in his role without much complication. But there was a scratch at the back of Katsuki’s head that made him wonder. If what *he* was saying was true—was what *Izuku* said true too?

“Taro has always been steadier between us!” Izuku happily mentioned to Momo when she complimented their tandem kayaking.

“Ah, he might be a little rough on the outside, but he’s super sweet and protective deep down,” Izuku endorsed when Katsuki checked his knee for scrapes when he accidentally fell.

“Taro makes me laugh all the time,” Izuku said with a grin as they started back to camp for the night. “It's part of the reason I fell for him. I enjoy his company a lot.”

Katsuki didn’t know why he cared about what was real or fake—but he did.

He tried his best to snap out of it by the time they sat down around the campfire. The orange light against the navy background was soothing. In this type of darkness, the stars above them were twinkling and clear as day. He could count the constellations as clearly as Izuku’s freckles. They were huddled around in a circle in their outdoor chairs, peacefully listening to the background music of the wildlife.

The fire was illuminating everyone’s faces as they laughed.

Currently, they were attempting to correctly place the wieners and marshmallows on their individual sticks. Izuku was hunched forward, the orange flame flickered and dancing in his glossy eyes. His stick had several marshmallows on it, and he was holding it directly over the flames. There was a tiny, over-excited glint in his eyes.

Katsuki sucked in his lips to stop from laughing when—just like he suspected—the marshmallows on Izuku’s stick melted and fell into the flames. Izuku gasped like he was surprised before attempting to save the last one. Then, when he did finish, the lone marshmallow was burned nearly fucking black.

The dork was visibly frustrated. Katsuki sighed in defeat when Izuku put *more* marshmallows on his stick. Then repeated the same thing.

Katsuki decided to have mercy on the poor man.

“You’re going to burn it like that, De—Darling,” Katsuki finally commented. “Here. If you want it gooier on the inside, you’re supposed to hold it down to the embers. Not on top of the

flames.”

Green eyes looked towards him, shimmering with all the light of the stars and the fire.

Katsuki easily scooched over, and placed Izuku’s hand in his. With care, he guided Izuku’s hand downwards to place the marshmallow above the greyer ashen part of the wood. The tiny embers floated up into the air and Izuku’s smile widened.

Katsuki waited until the marshmallow seemed like the perfect temperature. He then carefully took it from Izuku and with precise technique, made the perfect smore. He turned to give it to Izuku who was staring at him like he was superman or something.

“Thank you,” the freckled man said happily. “Ah, this is so exciting.”

Katsuki wondered if this was Izuku’s first smore.

He watched how Izuku carefully held it in his hands and took a small bite, humming happily as the sweet treat melted against his tongue. There was a hint of leftover white marshmallow on the corners of his lips when he finished.

Out of instincts, or out of trying to make sure they still looked like a sappy couple, Katsuki reached forward. He swiped the bits of food off Izuku’s lip carefully.

“You always make such a fucking mess,” Katsuki mumbled as he cleaned him up.

Izuku blushed deeply and mumbled ‘thank you’. His eyes skirted off with that same shy gaze in them.

“Hey, I just want to say sorry about leaving you guys in the woods,” Momo said suddenly, breaking the moment. “It was my idea and I’m still feeling guilty about it.”

“Don’t worry!” Izuku gave a charming chuckle. “It was, uh, good bonding time for us like you said.” He then reached for Katsuki’s hand and squeezed it lightly.

“You know, I’m a couples’ therapist,” Momo said softly. She leaned forward and Katsuki decided he didn’t like where this was going one damn bit. “I had originally thought it was a good idea because you guys argue a lot. I want to make up for the woods incident with an actual free session.”

If there was one thing Katsuki hated, it was fucking shrinks.

In his humble opinion, he didn’t need someone poking around in his head and bringing forward all the things he didn’t need to think about. He was a perfectly fine and well-oiled killing machine without all that emotional shit.

“Arguing is our love language,” Katsuki replied with a sarcastic smile. He unhappily leaned back in his chair and shot Momo a challenging glare. “I’m sure a lot of you guys argue with your partner too.”

“Ah, Mina and I don’t argue,” Eijiro chuckled. He proudly pointed to his chest with his thumb with a grin. “She tells me to shut up and I do!”

Mina smiled at Eijiro and patted him on the head lovingly.

“Why do you think you two argue so much, Taro and Hiroji?”

“Consider it foreplay,” Katsuki defensively snapped. “I like getting my husband flustered.”

Izuku frowned at him, and he could tell the freckled man resisted elbowing him in the side. “W-We’re just working through things, that’s all. We decided to take this vacation because as you see we argue but this has been good for us. I’m sorry, we don’t mean to cause anyone any worries or ruin your vacations.”

“Well, why don’t you tell me something unique about yourselves? As individuals.” Momo smiled at them. “We all can share something!”

“Unique?” Izuku questioned, tilting his head.

“Mhm! It can be anything,” Momo said happily. The smile on her face was welcoming, but the feeling inside of Katsuki’s chest was not. “Something about you that not a lot of people know, or you think doesn’t happen a lot to many people. For example, I was switched at birth. I ended up finding my real parents in my teens, so I have two sets of parents now.”

“Oh!” Eijiro spoke up. “I have black hair naturally, but I dye it.”

“I was struck by lightning once as a child,” Shouto added. “It activated my heterochromia condition.”

Everyone went around sharing a small bit of themselves, making a safe, cozy environment. But Katsuki wasn’t exactly keen on the idea. No matter how easy going everyone seemed to be.

So, Katsuki kept his mouth shut.

He frowned deeply but didn’t let go of Izuku’s hand. He curiously peered over to his faux husband. Izuku had his lips pressed in a thin line, contemplative, as if he was thinking of something.

“I...I overcame a small lisp when I was younger,” Izuku confessed in a small voice. “I had selective mutism as a child, so I ended up being a bit late on my speech development.”

Katsuki’s whole body went still in time.

The flame stopped flickering, the birds stopped chirping and all his senses ceased registering the world around him.

A lisp? He thought distantly.

That part of his brain tugged and screamed at him as he gradually turned towards Izuku. He unwillingly heard that tiny, small voice from his childhood and dreams. The one that always spoke out to him and cared. He was slightly surprised how easily he was triggered into thinking about those darkened nightmares. But the idea of a lisp reminded the blond of his blurry faced savior.

He watched the color of the flames dance and swirl against Izuku's green curls and in his eyes.

A piece of his heart panged unknowingly.

"I have lucid dreams," Katsuki admitted, feeling compelled by the bit of information Izuku dropped. All eyes turned to him, possibly surprised at the lucid dreaming part but more so at the fact he spoke. "So I, uh, wake up feeling like I slept a long time but I don't feel well rested."

"That probably adds to your grouchy factor a lot," Momo said thoughtfully and Katsuki soured a bit. "What do you dream about?"

"Nothing important," he mumbled back. "Uh...fish sticks."

"Aw, come on now. Don't lie. We're all having a good, honest time with each other."

"I...I dream about this boy I knew when I was younger."

"A boy?"

This time Izuku's eyes turned to him curiously.

"Yeah. We spent a full year together from the ages seven to eight," Katsuki confessed.

He stared into the flames, feeling lost a bit.

Hearing about Izuku's lisp pushed him back into that part of his headspace. It was dark, neglected, and covered in cobwebs. He slowly dusted off the opaque broken fragments of memories as he gazed into the flickering flames.

"What was the boy's name?" Momo said evenly. "He must be a big part of your life to appear in your dreams repeatedly."

"I actually can't remember what he looks like or even his name," Katsuki said quietly, feeling oddly ashamed as he struggled to gaze into the foggy memories. "Shitty of me, I know."

"Well. Why do you think you get these dreams? Especially if you can't physically place what he looks like."

Katsuki pressed his lips in a thin line. "I think I get the dreams a lot because part of me wants to remember him—but a large part of me doesn't so he stays blurry and unclear."

"What does that boy mean to you?" Momo asked carefully.

Katsuki quickly shook his head when he could feel a lock on that volt in his mind come undone. It cracked open and pieces of darkness seeped out. He took a deep breath and decided to close it again.

“Nothing,” he backtracked. “It’s, uh, not that important.”

“You don’t have to answer if you don’t want to,” Momo said in a gentle voice and Katsuki cursed. Damn she was good at her fucking job. “But I appreciate you offering up that bit of info, I would love to know what the boy meant to you if you dream of him so often.”

That volt cracked open again. He heard the boy’s laugh tangling with that same haunting melody of violins.

“I...I guess he meant a lot,” Katsuki said. He averted his eyes away from everyone to the ground below him. His chest was in an odd limbo, feeling both lighter—relieved—but churning about like he was finally allowing himself to feel. “He was one of the few people I ever met that cared about me. But I don’t want to remember him all that much.”

“Why do you think you’re suppressing him if he means that much to you?”

“Remembering him reminds me of how little my mother cared about me,” Katsuki hissed bitterly. His face automatically twisted in a scowl, feeling angry but guilty in the same breath. “She cared. She did—but within her limitations as an irresponsible gambler and drug addict. She had left me in the streets to fend for myself. I was wandering around worried about *her* while I nearly fucking died of *hypothermia*.”

He could feel everyone’s eyes crawling on him—especially Izuku’s.

He wanted to stop the words from tumbling out but soon that volt cracked open, and it all came rushing forward.

“If he cared about you, why does it make you feel angry?” Momo questioned.

“It—It makes me angry to think about how some random rich kid cared more about my wellbeing than my own mother ever did. And I feel guilty for being angry at my mother, since she’s passed. So, to avoid feeling angry, I don’t remember him,” Katsuki admitted.

It was a truth he hadn’t pieced together. However, it all clicked as to why his subconscious was constantly banging at the surface of his mind all the time.

“It’s hard to face a bitter fact like that, knowing he took care of me instead of the person who should’ve. He couldn’t even pronounce my name—had to call me *‘Kacchan.’* Some days it felt like he was the only person to ever love me, and I never saw him after that.”

“Well, besides Hiroji,” Momo said.

“What?” Katsuki frowned and gave her a confused stare. Who the hell was that?

“Hiroji loves you,” She repeated. She gestured to the man sitting next to him. “You two are married.”

And with that, he was snapped out of the spell.

He blinked rapidly, hearing Izuku's false name and suddenly recalled where exactly they were at. He stared in horror realizing he had let his fucking *mommy issues* spill out like that to a *therapist*. He saw all the pitiful, unneeded stares everyone was giving him. As if they fucking understood him more—but they didn't. Not a single damn soul here could ever understand him.

"Right. Yeah." Katsuki built his mental wall higher and let go of Izuku's hand—feeling a little too vulnerable. "Of course."

"I think remembering that boy will help you," Momo suggested. She clasped her hands and nodded happily. "You should allow yourself to reflect on that year and stop suppressing it so deeply. This way when you do feel like there are days that no one loves you, you can remember what he did—and lean on your partner for support. You love and care for Taro, don't you Hiroji?"

Katsuki cut his eye to the green haired man next to him.

He was stunned to see near glassy eyes staring at him in shock. Izuku's eyes were wide, as if he had seen some ghost and there was a phantom ghastliness to his features. He was stiff, frozen and he hadn't even moved his hand since Katsuki let it go.

"Ye—Yeah. I-I d-do," Izuku breathlessly whispered. His eyes searched all of Katsuki's features, studying them meticulously. He blinked back crocodile tears and Katsuki suddenly was deeply unhappy. "I lo-love and care about him a lot."

Sourness ate Katsuki from the inside out hearing those fake words.

Internally, he bitterly complimented how good of an actor Izuku was. With the way he was staring at him, anyone would think Izuku gave a shit about what he said. However, this was an assignment—and Izuku was only someone who was pretending to care about him.

All the grievous emotions flooded into Katsuki's core, taking him over. He regretted letting all that out and he wished he could rewind time. He realized his life's pain was minimized to play a part in an act that they were simply posing in. They were two people pretending to care about each other, and hearing Izuku say he did without any real base struck a chord.

It hurt, in a way.

He turned his head from Izuku, and the feeling of repulsion dragged against his skin.

He bitterly threw his smore into the flames and abruptly stood up.

"I'm going to go look at the stars or whatever," Katsuki muttered without sparing a single person a glance.

The hurt part of him was screaming for breathing room but to also have someone understand. Maybe it was Izuku's tone that felt like it was all nearly real, but he had to remind himself it

wasn't. Katsuki faced the ugly reality that he had spent all his life alone, and probably would continue to do so.

Even after this assignment.

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki didn't go too far. He stayed within the safety of the campsite. There were too many people around for Moore to stage any type of murder or kidnapping.

He was currently on the ledge of a cliff, sitting on a large moss-covered root of a giant tree. It jutted up from the ground in a delicate arch like nature's bench. The tree wept forward, protectively watching over the river they were just kayaking on.

Below him Katsuki could hear the sound of melodic laughter from other campers. It only added to the growing bitterness swelling within. He could see the stars from here, and endless green. Green. Green. Green.

He looked down sourly at the small leaf in his hand he plucked.

The sound of a snapped twig grabbed his attention and he turned. He was greeted with even more green—but a green he didn't fucking care for right now. Izuku was giving him a pathetic, pity-filled expression. Katsuki dug a glare into Izuku. He could see the rims of his big eyes slightly red in the night setting but was unsure.

Katsuki huffed, rolled his eyes, and turned back around.

"Came to check up on your *husband*?" he asked mockingly. He tore the green leaf in his hands in two aggressively with a sneer. "You know, you don't have to be attached to my ass all the time."

Izuku didn't respond.

The freckled man stepped forward carefully, moving aside some hanging vines and being mindful not to trip on the roots that were laced all around. He sat down next to Katsuki on the arched root. He quietly stared into the sky with him.

Katsuki waited for Izuku to say something—but nothing came.

They stayed there in silence for at least an hour, watching the stars as Katsuki plucked little leaf after tiny leaf from the ground.

Red and green eyes looked up solemnly at the constellations.

"I wonder if certain things are written in the stars," Izuku said with a blue undertone. He kept his glossy eyes trained up towards the twinkling sky. "Do you believe in fate, Katsuki?"

"No," Katsuki answered easily. He shredded another leaf. "Fate doesn't exist."

"Why do you think that?"

“Because the only thing that’s real is the consequences for your actions,” Katsuki said curtly. “We all have free will over our decisions and blaming *fate* on the outcome is an easy scapegoat. But I’m guessing *you* believe in fate.”

“It depends,” Izuku’s small voice said. “Usually I don’t, but sometimes it’s hard to ignore the signs.”

The sullen green-eyed man grew quiet before shifting slightly and looking down at his feet.

Katsuki didn’t say another word, not really liking the idea of entertaining Izuku’s hopeless romanticism at the moment. The wound of talking about his mother and his unknown savior was too fresh. This is why he hated discussing it. It always felt like someone was sinking their thumb in the open wound on his heart until he bled. His chest was clenching unbearably, and he felt a little too raw.

Katsuki turned and caught sight of Izuku’s eyes studying him in a completely different light. The other man’s mouth was taut, as if wanting to speak but was being held back by an unknown force.

It twisted Katsuki’s heart in a way he didn’t care for.

So, he turned forward again, looking up at the sky.

“D-Do you believe it’s possible for two people to be meant to be in each other’s lives?” Izuku suddenly asked. He timidly scooched over on the root, closer to Katsuki. Shy green eyes looked down at the leaf in Katsuki’s hand. “For example, let’s say, if they were forcefully separated the first time, fate would bring them back together...yeah?”

Katsuki huffed. Izuku reached out a hand for his, and he shifted away coldly.

“Izuku. I don’t really care about this romantic shit right now—”

“—It’s not romantic,” Izuku corrected, swiftly retracting his hand. He pressed it in his lap and hung his head. “I-I’m just talking. I wanted to know how you would feel about possibly having...a person you were meant to cross paths with.”

Katsuki scoffed.

“It sounds over optimistic,” he cut down unkindly. “I don’t believe two people are destined to meet each other. Fate doesn’t bring them together because fate isn’t *real*. No one on this dumb earth is destined to meet anyone. The only thing we’re destined for is death.”

Izuku didn’t say anything after that. Just stared at him with a sad smile.

They sat alone in a peculiar type of silence Katsuki couldn’t place his finger on. It rotated between Izuku looking at the stars, then looking at him as if he was equally as perplexing. Then slowly Katsuki found himself looking at the forest shrubs, vines and how Izuku really did blend in with them all. But for a moment, he found himself thinking about Izuku’s eyes.

Every time he tried to move his thoughts away from those big green eyes—the visual of them staring at him in that shocked manner came back. It felt nearly haunting.

Then, they both glanced up once more at the night sky to see two shooting stars falling at the same time. The sparkling white lights shot down across the atmosphere, adding more splendor to the already decorated sky above them. Katsuki watched as the twin stars fell in tandem, intertwining in a way that crossed their paths among the glittering constellations.

Katsuki wasn't one for wishes. He wasn't one for hoping—but in that moment as he thought of the phantom of a boy from his past, he wished for one thing.

I hope you're doing well.

He turned to Izuku, who was glancing up at the stars with a melancholy expression.

Katsuki quietly asked, "What did you wish for?"

Izuku smiled at him in a way he never had before. Viridian eyes were heavy with a thousand unspoken words.

"I have nothing to wish for anymore. My one wish has already come true."

☽ ☽ ☽

That night, Katsuki's mind drifted into sleep a little bit differently, still guided by the distant echoing of violins in his head.

He kept seeing green all around him in the forest and it was pulling him in a direction he was unsure of.

He didn't want to take Momo's advice, but he found himself lying in the sleeping bag next to a strangely noiseless Izuku that night feeling odd. They didn't make a scene or fuss about sharing the sleeping bag in the chill night. Katsuki easily turned away from the other man. Just as he was on the edge of sleep, Izuku whispered 'goodnight' with a crack in his voice. After that, a deafening silence pierced through him as he had no choice but to reflect upon what he let out into the ether.

He closed his eyes and wandered to that dark, neglected part of his mind. He couldn't tell the difference between what was the dream and what was his vivid imagination. There, in the far recesses, he clearly saw a giant steel volt. It was covered in dust, cracked at the edges and pieces of opaque glass were shattered on the ground beneath it.

He walked towards one sparkling piece carefully, feeling the cut and crunch of glass underneath his feet. The volt slid open, seeping darkness onto the ground. When the blackness touched that sparkling piece of foggy glass—the glass turned clear.

He bent down and picked it up, peering through the looking glass to see a very clear memory.

Inside, he could see his childhood less blurred. The sun was shining, and the sound of two boys laughing in the summer sun was as crisp as fresh rain. He could feel the playful pull of a smaller hand in his as they splashed up and down in puddles. He was chasing behind the boy who had dark curly hair bouncing in the wind.

Then the boy turned around and smiled at him.

“I’m so happy we’re friends, Kacchan!”

When Katsuki opened his eyes that next morning, he remembered a tiny new detail.

It was small, but it was as important as the key on a large lock. The part of the fog covering the boy’s eyes wafted away like smog in the wind to reveal Katsuki’s favorite color.

The boy had green eyes.

Chapter End Notes

I hope you enjoyed 💕 Please let me know what you think below! I love questions, comments, screams, and hearing everyone's thoughts as I progress through this story. Thanks so much for reading 🧡💚

Chapter 6: Interlude I

Chapter Summary

(Interlude): An intervening or interruptive period, space, or event.

Chapter Notes

Hello! Welcome back to the choochoo train of pain.

First, thank you to my moon and stars, LunaToons, for always pushing me to be better and betaing. 💕 I hope you all enjoy reading!

Warnings: Heavy child neglect and poor parenting. Implied off screen child abuse.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 6 - Interlude I

.

.

.

Katsuki remembered he was seven years old when he declared his favorite color was green.

He came to this conclusion when his first friend looked at him. He could remember it now, without the weight of suppression against his fragile memory. He could remember how the kind boy had given him all his winter clothes and junk food he found somewhere.

“Can I call you Kacchan?” The blurry faced boy asked. His green eyes were now gleaming through the fog surrounding him like glowing gemstones.

Katsuki remembered how his heart did another flip as he squeezed the hand in his.

“Ye-Yeah,” he replied. He wasn’t sure if he stammered from the cold or the warm feeling inside of his chest. “Kacchan works. What’s your name?”

The boy smiled through the fog surrounding him and answered eagerly. “It’s [illegible].”

It was like violent static noise.

That piece of his memory was still unclear through the reflection. He could see pretty, bright green eyes through the haze now, but he struggled to see any other details beside dark, curly hair. The color he was unsure of.

Was it also green? Or was it black? It could've possibly been a midnight blue or deep purple. Whichever the case, the curls on the other boy's hair were dark with an overlay of another color from what Katsuki could remember.

And Katsuki decided then, to remember.

He remembered the boy departed after that, saying he had to hurry off. Katsuki didn't want him to go, still eager for more warm droplets of kindness in the cold winter. He stared desperately at the boy who gave him a reassuring smile.

"Will you be back?" Katsuki had asked.

He didn't let go of the hand in his. He thought of his mom and how this boy was the closest thing to a friend he'd ever had.

The other boy stared at him, seeming almost shocked at the sudden declaration.

"I-If you want me to come back, I'll come back, Kacchan," his new friend said.

"I do," Katsuki nodded eagerly at the prospect of not being alone anymore. "I want you to come back."

Gradually, a bright, gap tooth smile was given to him. "Okay! I'll come back tomorrow. Just for you, Kacchan. I have to go now though. Have a good night!"

Katsuki smiled sadly at his kind savior and said goodnight too.

There was an inkling of bitterness bubbling in red eyes when the other boy walked away.

Katsuki sourly assumed the other boy probably was going to a nice, warm home while he was stuck here. In the cold streets in the dingy alleyway. When his savior was fully out of sight, Katsuki forced back tears. The frigid loneliness in his bones ached deeper than the winter cold.

He sauntered back to the sketchy alleyway with his head down. Out of caution, Katsuki zipped his bag of food inside of his new puffy winter jacket in an attempt to hide it. He knew they wouldn't do anything because his mom had made friends with them—but he was still fearful being so small.

He had never been alone like this, and he wondered if someone would try to hurt him.

The young blond strolled past all the various homeless people who lived on the same street. Several eyes raked him up and down, taking in his new clothes with curiosity. People were assessing him, probably wondering how he went from wearing nearly nothing to this shiny new wardrobe.

Katsuki went to bed in the tiny, thin tent that night feeling slightly warmer.

The howling wind rattled the tent like an earthquake as Katsuki tucked himself under the thin blanket he found a few weeks ago in the dumpster. He kept all his new clothes on to stay warm as he quietly ate the various candy bars, chips, and juices with a thankful heart and stomach.

In his dreams that night, he saw pretty green eyes.

☽ ☽ ☽

The boy with kind green eyes came back the next day just like he said he would. Katsuki was so happy that he then asked him to come back again after a day of playing together. The smaller boy seemed shy but overjoyed that Katsuki wanted his company.

So, the boy with green eyes came back every day that week at the same time.

The sky was always bleeding from dark orange to desaturated blue when his mysterious savior arrived. He always came bearing new clothes, blankets, and food for him each day. To accompany these gifts, his smile was bright as the sun and his hair was as soft looking like the clouds.

Katsuki noted how the first day he came back, the boy was wearing brand new clothes, nearly identical to the ones he gave up to Katsuki. Then the following day, he had come with more food and *blankets*. Clean, warm blankets that smelled like fresh linens.

The smaller boy bundled him up in his shabby tent like he was some puppy to be taken care of.

Young Katsuki was curious about his friend. He was especially inquisitive about the white bandage on his friend's face. It was covering his right eye and caked with dark red blood in several spots. Whatever wound was beneath it seemed to be nasty.

"What happened to your other eye?" Katsuki asked that week. "It looks painful."

He reached out to touch it, but before he could his friend harshly flinched away.

The action made young Katsuki freeze, shocked at how quickly his friend's bubbly demeanor changed. The loud laughter came to an immediate halt and the only visible green eye looked away from him. His friend's small, gloved hands nervously toyed with the hems of his red coat.

"S'nothing," his friend clearly lied. The small voice used made Katsuki disgruntled. "I was playing with my big brother, and I fell. I'm clumsy."

He itched to call out the fib, but Katsuki didn't want to push and scare his new friend off.

"Okay," Katsuki replied slowly. He narrowed his eyes slightly with a deep frown. "Well. Tell your brother not to play so rough. You need to see."

His protective side stirred up a little bit.

Katsuki decided if he ever met his new friend's big brother, he would want to have a word.

He imagined the big brother to be slightly older, and probably larger in stature than either of them. But he didn't care at the moment. Seeing blood seep through the white bandage angered Katsuki deeply. The fiery young blond was always someone who was more protective than the average person because of his dynamic with his mother.

But he didn't push it.

He wanted the other boy to stay, so he let his friend lead the conversation back to comics and his favorite superheroes. Deep down, Katsuki wanted his friend to stay with him and *never* leave. He had hoped his mother would come back—she had to—but he didn't know when.

Maybe his friend could stay with him until she came back? It had to be soon. She had been gone for so long already.

Every day that week they talked, and his new friend brought him more supplies. And every day, when his friend's little yellow watch read 22:22, he would say he had to go.

Young Katsuki was lonely, confused, but he figured his friend had parents who were probably looking for him too. Maybe they let him go out to play after school but told him he had to come back at a specific time.

He watched the green-eyed boy run home. Back to whatever warmth he was living in while Katsuki was stranded in the cold.

It made Katsuki hopefully wonder.

That Monday of the following week, while cooped up in his tent laughing and talking, Katsuki took a moment to pause. He looked at his friend's sparky clothes and the warm blush on his cheeks in a longing manner. He eyed the cleanliness of the other boy. His friend smelled like mint and cinnamon. Katsuki, shamefully, could smell the unappealing must wafting on his own body.

Katsuki swallowed dryly and leaned in close to his friend's face.

"Can I...Can I come home with you?" Katsuki's voice was full of hope.

But the other boy stiffened.

"Home? With me?" His friend clarified.

Katsuki nodded eagerly.

His little heart fluttered, thinking about a possible warm shower and the opportunity to clean his hair. He hated walking around feeling dirty, smelly, and gross. However, his heart started sinking when his friend looked down at the bundle of blankets underneath them.

His new friend nervously plucked at the cotton blanket under them.

“I-I’m sorry, Kacchan,” the other boy whispered wearily. “I don’t think you should.”

Katsuki’s heart dropped straight to the bottom of his stomach fast enough to make him nauseous.

“*Why*?” Katsuki hissed.

His eyes immediately started stinging with salty tears at the denial. He knew it would be a stretch. He fucking *knew* but still he thought *maybe*. His new friend had been so kind but—but hearing that refusal felt like a slap in the face. A sad green eye gazed at him and even though the other was bandaged up, Katsuki knew it was staring at him with the same amount of useless pity.

His friend reached a hand forward to steady his shaking fists. “You don’t want to come home s’with me—”

“—Yes I do.” Katsuki’s tone was forceful. “Would your parents not want me there? Is that the problem? Am I—Am I too dirty for them? Would they freak out?”

“No, Kacchan. I-It’s not that—”

“—Then *what*?” Katsuki snatched his hand away and all the tears poured down. “Why the hell *not*? You—You have *clothes* and *food*. You wear all this pretty fancy stuff all the time and smell nice like soap. I smell horrible and I’m dirty and sleep in this dirty tent. You probably get to sleep in a *bed*! Why can’t you let me come home with you?!”

“It’s—” His friend paused. The bottom of his lip started quivering and he shook his head as if trying to silently communicate with him. “Kacchan. You’re better here, you’re *safe* here.”

Safe.

Katsuki sourly glanced around at the shabby tent that had holes in it.

A gust of winter air came through at that moment, reminding him how close to freezing to death he was. The winter breeze caressed his cheeks and nose, making him shiver harshly. Red eyes blinked through the stinging tears as he stared at his friend, who also shivered.

Then it clicked.

His friend would stop shivering at 22:22. He would run home and get in bed, get a bath and probably a hug. But Katsuki would keep shivering long after 22:22.

The anger inside of him churned until it boiled.

“Get out,” Katsuki hissed.

His fists shook as he surveyed all the blankets and clothes. He tried to stop the emotions inside of him from tittering over, but he couldn’t. It all built up high until it collapsed within

him. No hot meals. No showers. No more school. No more seeing his *mom*. Being stuck in this fucking *tent*. He had no other family or anywhere to even *go*.

“Wh-What? Kacchan, you don’t mean that—”

“—I said get out!” Katsuki screamed.

He stood up, head knocking the top of the plastic tent and he grabbed his friend by his yellow scarf around his neck. He ignored all the crying and screaming from his new friend as he wrestled him down and unzipped his shabby excuse for a home. With all his strength, jealousy, and resentment, Katsuki threw out the boy with green eyes into the street straight into the snow.

Watery green eyes looked at him, hurt in disbelief. “Ka-Kacchan—”

“Just leave me *alone*!” Katsuki yelled. His chest heaved as he started crying hot tears that immediately froze on his skin. “Go run home to your precious mommy and daddy and leave me to fucking freeze to death!”

He zipped up his tent before his friend could come back in. He could see the shadow of two tiny hands on the door of the tent and hear all the little sobs.

“Kacchan! I’m sorry! Please. Please, let me back in,” his friend said. Sniffles, sobs, and more all came pouring out. “Puh—please. Ka-Kacchan…”

Katsuki covered his ears and screwed his eyes shut.

He choked back a sob as he shut out the only person who cared. Part of him was screaming to let his new friend back in while the other half was fed up with being homeless and burned to lash out.

He wanted his mom. He wanted her to come back and he wanted to stop feeling so dirty. He cried harder until he could hear nothing—and no one but his own heart breaking.

When Katsuki finally calmed down, his friend was gone. He unzipped the tent, and in the dark night he could see the scattered snow prints of tiny feet wandering off out of the alleyway.

He wondered if it was after 22:22.

☽ ☽ ☽

The next morning, Katsuki had a little bit of remorse for how he treated his new friend.

His tiny heart was still jealous and bitter, but he felt loneliness stronger than either of those emotions. He glanced around at all the other homeless people gathered who were heating themselves up by the fire in the metal bins, talking amongst themselves. They all were huddled with someone. Paired off or in groups with friends. The ones who weren’t were sleeping off to the side or muttering.

Katsuki went with his usual movements.

Every morning he searched for his mother with a heavy heart. This was officially the sixth week of him searching for her with a heart full of fragile hope.

He went his normal route, guessing where she probably might be at. He stopped at her favorite clothing store. Her favorite restaurant. Her favorite park. He even looked around a certain street with adults who played card games, he didn't know what they were exactly, but he knew his mother liked being there.

When he found no trace of her, he wandered back to her favorite park and sat there by himself.

Katsuki gazed at the families there with deep longing.

He watched a young mother hug her child with a warm embrace. The pair giggled as she spun the toddler around, eliciting giggles and cheers from the happy child. He wrinkled his nose a bit to force the tears back, but they came rushing forward like a stampede. One by one each drop fell onto his blue jeans, leaving behind a wet stain.

He tried to ease his mind as he thought about the last time he saw her.

Her red eyes had been gentle, motherly, and full of love. The two of them had been living out of the tent for about two months by that point.

Before that, they had a house that was full of his favorite things like games, toys and his dad was alive. Katsuki's childhood had been filled with nothing but bright, radiant colors. He loved his mom and dad, his room and everything in his life.

However, that all changed quickly when his father grew ill when he was six. That shiny light in his home turned off with the snap of Fate's fingers when she commanded his father's spirit to leave his body. Katsuki's colorful world was smothered in dull hues as he stood over that grey tombstone that read 'Bakugou Masaru' dressed in all black.

Things became rocky after the funeral.

His mom had to get a full time job and he spent a lot of time with babysitters. But when he was at home, things became strained. He ate less. Bathed less. His mom cried more. Soon after he turned seven, people tried to take him from what he could remember. Men and women in fancy suits with shiny clipboards. They said that he was going to go elsewhere and get a new family—one that could properly take care of him.

Katsuki didn't want to be separated from her though.

His dad made him promise to watch after her and said that she needed him.

"Katsuki," he could recall his father saying right before he passed. His brown eyes were nearly dull and lifeless as he laid on that bed sick with death. "Katsuki. Please take care of your mother. She needs someone there…to help her be better. She needs you."

Katsuki agreed with tears in his eyes.

He was *needed* and those damn people in suits didn't understand that. Clearly, his mom didn't want to abandon him either. She looked horrified that day when the lady with black hair told her that he would be going somewhere else.

That night, he remembered that he and his mom had left before the people in suits could come back.

At first, Katsuki was unhappy and fussy. He was unsure why they were leaving their warm home. He didn't want to go, it was his favorite place. It smelled like sweet cinnamon like his father used to and young Katsuki wasn't ready to let that go. But it didn't matter what he wanted—his mom said they *had* to go.

He asked if they would ever go back home, and his mother curtly said no.

If they ever were to go back home, they would be separated and Katsuki had to learn to grow up. He resisted throwing a fit as he glanced around his once warm home.

He could see a ghost visual of his father in the home that night waving goodbye to him. His father's phantom mouthed 'take care of her' as he gradually grew faint. Then finally, the figure of his imagination fully faded sadly as they climbed out the side window.

The sadness in young Katsuki at that departure stuck with him for years to come.

He and his mother then snuck away in the night and left behind nearly everything. Katsuki only took his All Might action figure and that was all he was allowed. They had been on the train for a long time, the cityscapes passing them by for hours. Katsuki had lifted his All Might action figure up to the window as the trees whizzed by in the distance, making it seem like he was flying.

When they arrived that day, they were in Tokyo. His mom purchased a new mini home for them. She said it was like camping, but in the city! Which Katsuki thought was neat since it was only autumn. The two of them found an alleyway hidden away from the world.

She trained him well to avoid anyone who might look suspicious so they wouldn't be separated. Katsuki followed her instructions carefully because he wouldn't ever want to leave his mom. She needed him. She really did—especially on the days she would cry and ask the sky to bring back his dad.

Katsuki was convinced it was going to be the two of them together forever.

Or at least he thought.

"Mommy needs some time to get things together. Okay?" She had explained. She caressed his hair and left him with his favorite All Might action figure. "You're a big boy now and can handle yourself for a bit. When I come back, we'll have a home, and you'll have all the comics and toys you can think of. Just stay right here until I get back and don't let *anyone* take you, okay? I love you."

Katsuki had agreed. He nodded and watched her walk away with a pretty smile on her face.

He replayed that memory over and over again like a broken tape.

“Stay right here.”

“Mommy will be back.”

“I love you.”

Maybe she was lost. Grown-ups could get lost too, not just kids, right? She said they wouldn’t be separated so there was no way she left him.

...Right?

☽ ☽ ☽

After doing his daily sweep of her in the area *twice* with no luck, Katsuki finally settled down in front of the violinist who endlessly played.

The smoothing music was gentle enough to calm him down long enough to realize he had been upset at the wrong person. He thought about kind green eyes and all the warm blankets that he had been given. He doesn’t know why he even asked to go home with him when he knew he had to look for his mother.

He sniffed under his arms again a little bit and flinched back.

The winter day started to bleed into orange early in the afternoon like he had every day before. Katsuki anticipated this being the first day out of the week his friend wouldn’t return. He probably was sobbing to his parents about the mean boy who harshly rejected his kindness.

But he was soon proven wrong, when the very person he thought wouldn’t come back, did.

Wandering around the corner, crying with puffy eyes and a red nose was the boy with green eyes.

Katsuki felt his heart squeeze when he made eye contact with that one watery green eye.

“Izuku?” He spoke.

His new friend walked up to him sobbing and holding out his arms for him.

“Kacchan. I-I’m so-sorry—” the smaller boy cried. His voice was raspy as though he had been crying all day. “P-Please don’t be mad, Kacchan. I don’t want you to be mad at me.”

Katsuki tried to tell him that *he* should be the one that’s sorry, but the tiny hands of his friend grabbed him immediately. Short arms encircled him, and his friend tucked his head into his neck and cried more.

“Yo-You’re my only fr-friend and I don’t wa-want you to be mad,” the weeping continued. “B-But I-I can’t take you home. I just *can’t*. *Please*. My big brother s’mean and I don’t want him to hurt you too.”

Too.

Katsuki froze when he heard that word.

He reeled back a bit to study the other boy who was sniffling. Snot ran down his chubby face in the cold and his cheeks were pinked from a combination of crying and the chilly weather.

Katsuki frowned deeply as he considered the bloodied bandage in a new light. He lifted a hand to touch it, and this time his friend didn’t shy away. The smaller boy flinched in pain but allowed Katsuki to trace it. From underneath the thin layer of material, Katsuki could feel the swelling of a black eye and a large cut.

“Did he do this to your eye?” Katsuki asked, knowing the answer already.

That lone green eye glanced off to the side, fear circling inside of it.

“Ye-Yes, but you can’t tell anyone,” his friend whispered dreadfully. “I-I’m not supposed to tell *anyone*, Kacchan. I could get in a lot of trouble if they found out I was talking about it.”

So, he was right.

Katsuki imagined whatever big brother his friend had to be cruel, ugly, and vicious for picking on someone smaller than him. But what the fuck was up with *family* picking on him? Katsuki couldn’t fathom hurting someone he considered family.

“Trouble with *who*?” Katsuki’s nostrils flared in rage. “Why don’t you tell your parents and make him stop?”

“*Please*,” his new friend pleaded. His question went unanswered as the smaller boy hugged him tighter. “You have to *promise*. You won’t tell anyone.”

The tiny voice cracked, and it tugged at Katsuki’s heart.

He hesitantly wrapped his arms around his friend, slightly self-conscious of his unpleasant odor. But he was more compelled to suddenly protect the other boy in his embrace. As the smaller boy cried into his neck, Katsuki promised himself if he ever met this big brother, he would beat him up—or kill him.

“I promise,” Katsuki whispered. He hugged him tighter and buried his face into the other child’s fuzzy hat. “I’m sorry too. I shouldn’t have gotten mad at you yesterday without hearing why. I get angry a lot...it’s hard to not feel angry sometimes.”

“It’s okay, Kacchan. I forgive you,” the smaller boy said back. “I understand you get angry and use a lot of bad words. That’s why I like you.”

Katsuki felt tears prickling at his eyes at the small glimpse of acceptance.

When they pulled back from their embrace, both boys were smiling at each other. All bad feelings and icky thoughts dissolved into nothing as Katsuki looked into that large pretty green eye.

It was only when they were finally holding hands again, Katsuki noticed the music had stopped playing.

Katsuki turned curiously towards the elderly man. The violinist was now sitting on the ground, watching them while his calloused hands were cradling his violin. The liver spotted man didn't say a word as his dark brown eyes gazed at them. His expression was full of adoration and his lips had a small, half lopped smile.

This was the first time Katsuki had ever heard him stop playing. It made the young blond curious *why*—but before he could ask, there was a small tug at his arm.

"Kacchan, I-I found a better place for you to sleep if you want," his friend proposed. "I found it yesterday when I was walking."

Katsuki straightened out, not expecting those words. He turned back to the smaller boy. "What do you mean?"

His new friend fiddled with the hems on his jacket and squeezed their intertwined fingers.

"I know I ca-can't take you home s'with me, but I found a place that would be warmer and safer."

Katsuki's heart leaped against his sternum.

Yes. Absolutely *yes*.

He didn't even care about what place his friend was possibly referring to because the idea of somewhere warm was amazing. The numbness at the end of his toes and fingertips was eating away at his nerves to the point it was beginning to burn. Katsuki nearly felt like crying after hearing the proposal. The excited young blond was about to jump at the offer but halted.

He glanced at the shabby tent and saw a ghost visual of his mother waving at him. She mouthed the words 'stay right here' and pointed to the tent. Suddenly he felt like sharp hooks were sunk into the flesh of his heels keeping him stuck in place.

"I...I can't go too far," Katsuki whispered. The visual of her waving at him faded slowly with the falling snow. His heart sank down low again, and he hung his head in defeat. "My mom said she would be back for me. I don't want to go too far off and miss her one day. She needs me."

"It's not far at all!" His friend reassured with a bright smile. "I remembered what you said about your mom, so I made sure it was close. Follow me, Kacchan!"

Katsuki perked up again, a tiny flicker of hope growing in his chest.

☽ ☽ ☽

His friend helped gather his belongings and they walked side by side to a place that was still in the more worn down, neglected parts of the city. They followed the pathway of crooked sidewalk nearby. It winded around a corner near the alley like promised. The concrete was cracked and uneven, showing no one had tended to it in years.

By the time they arrived at the place his friend was talking about, Katsuki felt his heart beating hectically.

They were standing in front of an abandoned church.

The building was tilted slightly, slanted on the ground as if the wind had knocked against it hard enough to make it lean. The color was white, and the shape was pointy on top. At the peak was the symbol of what Katsuki could make out to be a rusted golden cross. He remembered his mother talking about these types of churches, saying that it was a religion from abroad her mother tried to get her into, but she never wanted to.

All the paint on the outside was chipped and worn, as if the building was showing how it was just as neglected as Katsuki. There were wooden boards on all the doors to prevent entry. Katsuki wondered just how *this* was supposed to be his new home—but quickly his friend showed him the way.

The tinier boy motioned with his head and ran to the back of the building. Katsuki curiously followed, and when he peered around the corner, he saw the other boy lifting one wooden board. The rusted screws fell out easily revealing a small entrance leading inside. It was too small for grown-ups but just large enough for him and his new friend.

They both smiled wide at each other.

The smaller of the two squeezed in first and they did a funnel system to shovel all Katsuki's belongings inside. Then when he handed his All Mokight action figure to the smaller boy, Katsuki squeezed in. He stumbled in slightly, but quickly gained his footing. He looked up and all around him was pitch blackness except the shining of moonlight through the colorful stained-glass windows surrounding them.

Katsuki took a moment to stare upwards.

The ceilings were so high that it was the first time that Katsuki truly felt small. He felt microscopic as he stared up at all the beautiful windows covered in cobwebs. The moonlight peered through to cast down rays of light that were glittering with bright hues. Pink, blue, orange, and green hues scattered all around in the dark room. A myriad of colors decorated both boys standing in the middle of the abandoned church as they stared around in awe.

Katsuki looked at the boy next to him under the twinkling colors.

The little rays of light made him appear multi-colored and heavenly. Katsuki smiled thankfully. His savior of a friend then turned to him with a kind smile and told him to follow him. They walked down the long aisle together holding all his stuff.

Katsuki looked up, studying the large round stained-glass window in the center of the church. It was the biggest, and the focal point. It had a symbol of a red apple and green snake in the middle of its spiral. The snake circled around the apple, showing its fangs. Out of all the ethereal art inside, that one stood out to Katsuki, and small goosebumps ignited on his skin.

He kept his eyes trained on it until they went around to a backroom.

The smell of heavy dust tickled the back of Katsuki's nose as he looked at all the forgotten benches, books, and candles all covered with a sheet of transparent cobweb.

Then his friend stopped in front of a tiny door underneath the stairs. He placed down the bundle of clothes and blankets to open it. It revealed a tiny nook that looked as if someone had previously cleaned it. It lacked the dust layer and was straightened up to look neat. There were tiny shelves jutting out from the sides that had candles on them.

His friend stepped forward hesitantly into the dark nook and took a candle. He reached into his puffy red coat and pulled out a matchbox and fumbled with it until he struck a flame. He carefully lit the candle and set it on top of the tiny shelf.

"I cleaned this up for you, Kacchan," his friend said shyly. "I know it's not much, but you won't be in the cold anymore."

He turned to smile at Katsuki, and the young blond felt his heart skip a beat as he looked at the small space.

☽ ☽ ☽

That night his friend set him up in the tiny nook.

They used all the blankets to make the tiny nook seem like a fluffy fortress rather than a tiny hidden hole in an abandoned building. The candlelight made the atmosphere appear cozy and warmed the space. Everything was plush and his new friend said that he would bring him lots of pillows to make it even more comfortable for him.

Katsuki looked around the small space. It was as close to home as he could remember.

Afterwards, his new friend led him downstairs, where it was slightly creepy. They used the forgotten candles to light their way in the pitch blackness all the way to the bottom of the building. The tiny flames barely lit anything, but they could at least see a little bit in front of them.

The wooden floorboards changed to grey cracked cement as they made their way down some large steps. When they finally got to the bottom, they saw several rats run past and they screamed in shock. In the moment, his friend hastily clutched onto him in fear, and they then looked at each other. Tiny laughter bubbled up between them as they continued down.

His friend didn't stop clutching his arm and Katsuki puffed out his chest, liking the feeling of being needed and bigger.

He smiled privately at the smaller boy.

They got to the bottom of the basement and tucked away in the shabby corner was an open shower—or something of the sort. The shower head was there and there was a drain over the cracked white tiles in the corners. It looked dirty, a little moldy but for the most part it translated to one thing to Katsuki: he could finally clean himself.

Katsuki stared at his friend, and his friend happily gestured towards the shower. Katsuki muttered a quiet ‘thank you’ as they got closer to the forgotten shower. His new friend averted his gaze as Katsuki stripped down.

Slight shame gnawed at the young blond as he finally let his clothes drop and there was a clear ill-smelling stench in the air. He huddled into his body a bit, trying to draw back in the shame of his filth as he turned on the water.

The liquid felt almost foreign on his skin as it touched him for the first time in nearly two months. His body shivered a bit. The water wasn’t exactly warm, but it wasn’t cold either as he tried to adjust to it. He looked around for soap and found nothing. But before he could be sad about it, a tiny hand came forward and gave him a generic lavender bar of soap and a rag.

Red eyes widened and Katsuki turned to see his friend shyly smiling at him.

He took the items and looked at them carefully as the other boy turned away again. Katsuki started slowly scrubbing his body with the soap and rag, but as the pretty purple bubbles turned brown, he froze. He didn’t know why but he clammed up and his throat swelled.

He stood there frozen for a while, assessing the grim that had built up on his skin.

He tried to lather the layers of dirt away with the bar of soap in his hand, but it felt endless. More purple bubbles turned brown and Katsuki’s throat swelled as the water poured down on him. Tears pricked like needles at his eyes again and he couldn’t figure out why. He blinked rapidly, trying to push through the putrid smell and discomfort that strangled him.

What the hell was wrong with him?

He started to shake slightly, and his arm felt heavier as he attempted to clean his body.

He let out a quiet sob.

Quickly, his friend stepped forward and gently grabbed the bar of soap when Katsuki’s shaking grew crippling. The blond boy squeezed his eyes shut as he stayed frozen in place in shame. He wanted to disappear or act as though he wasn’t humiliated by his soiled body. The other boy helped scrub his body in the lukewarm water that didn’t blast at full power.

His friend didn’t seem to care about getting his clothes wet as he picked up the task.

Katsuki felt raw.

In that moment, he could feel the weight of poverty crushing down on him as he watched the purple soapsuds turn dingy brown. He closed his eyes, thinking maybe this filth would cause

his friend to think he was disgusting and leave him alone. However, the kind boy only smiled and helped clean him.

He even sang a stupid song to help keep Katsuki distracted.

“Clean the Kacchan until he’s happy,” the tiny voice of his friend recited in a sing-song tone as he lathered Katsuki’s hair. He foamed it until the bubbles went from brown to purple. “Clean him until he’s brand new! Clean him until he’s smiling and full of sunshine!”

Katsuki eventually sat on the cold tile and let himself be taken care of.

He listened to the little made-up song and found himself humming along with it. It distracted him enough from his shame that he didn’t feel too woeful. They harmonized those three lines over and over as Katsuki cried softly. His friend didn’t mention the filth, the tears, or even care about his dampened clothes.

Katsuki smiled painfully as he allowed the sprinkling water pouring on his face to mix with his salty tears.

☽ ☽ ☽

When he finally smelled like lavender and his body was scrubbed fully clean, the kind boy settled him into the cozy nook under the stairs. He was checking his little yellow watch a lot, and the time seemed to be inching closer to 22:22. Katsuki looked around his new abode and didn’t want the other boy to go.

He laid down in the heap of blankets and allowed himself to be tucked in. He gazed up at the boy with the bandaged eye who looked down at him happily.

“I hope this will be okay,” his friend said shyly as he finished bundling him up. “I know it’s not much, but it’ll keep you safe and warm at night when you’re not looking for your mom.”

“Th-This is great, thank you,” Katsuki said unsteadily.

He tried to grin but found himself overcome with gratitude when he felt the numbness in the tips of his fingers start to fade all the way. The blood came pulsing back in a rush that felt painful, but he welcomed it. Katsuki tried to desperately shove back the feeling of crying that was pushing at his eyes but couldn’t.

He smiled and choked back a sob. He covered his eyes and cried into the heels of his palms.

“Thank—Thank you so much,” Katsuki’s voice splintered at the edges as he shook. “I’m so sorry for being mean to you yesterday.”

His friend immediately laid down next to him, hugged him tight and wiped his tears.

“S’okay, Kacchan.”

☽ ☽ ☽

That was the beginning of a friendship Katsuki cherished that year.

In the mornings, Katsuki did his routine check for his mother. With each passing day without her, he could feel his unease increasingly gnaw through him until he started to taste acidic bile at the back of his throat. To distract himself, he focused on the one steady constant in his life: green eyes.

At the exact time every day, the boy with pretty green eyes met him in the plaza. They sat together for a while to listen to the violinist side by side on the bench where they met. The elderly man's eyes lit up whenever he saw them together and he grinned wide, showing off his crooked, rotten teeth.

They grinned back happily and always cheered and clapped for him at the end of every song.

Accompanied with that, the new place to stay allowed Katsuki to feel immensely better and safer. He didn't have to worry about the harsh winds of the winter storms nor showering. The coziness of the blankets insulated him enough that he was toasty inside of the small space. It was perfectly big enough for him and his friend to play in—and play they did.

He eventually learned his friend's favorite superhero comic was All Might as well, and they talked all evening about the comics.

His friend then started bringing him comics and posters with the bags of food after that. They taped the posters up on the walls inside of the tiny nook and they found flashlights for them to use instead of candles.

The pair of boys stayed under the covers a lot that winter making up stories and pretending they were real heroes. Some days they played make believe inside of the large church, jumping off the creaky wooden benches with blankets wrapped around their shoulders like capes. Other days they played tag, running up and down the church's squeaky wooden floors full of energy. Some nights they even did hide and seek or shadow puppets in the sparkling rays of light from the stained-glass.

The possibilities were endless as they ran as free as their imaginations.

Katsuki had never had this much fun, and it fed the lonely void in his chest.

Then every night at 22:22 his friend would tuck him in, hug him, and quietly wander off into the night back to wherever home was.

Katsuki felt cared for. He felt happy and nearly felt loved.

Then when the dark winter melted into bright spring, his friend's bandage came off.

Katsuki knew the other eye was probably green—but it didn't stop him from admiring the matching set in front of him. Whatever injury he had healed up smoothly and seeing the full face of his savior made young Katsuki's heart clench.

Green eyes. Such pretty, unique green eyes.

☽ ☽ ☽

One day they found themselves listening quietly to the violinist in the plaza.

Like always, the elder man played his haunting song on the ivory violin with a distant expression. As Katsuki listened on this day, he was finally able to pin down why this song was so different. Usually when the violinist played other songs, he played like a normal musician. He stood with his back straight and swayed softly with the enchanting melodies.

However, with this one particular song the man played, it was as though he was an entirely different person. He played it over and over until some days Katsuki could see his fingers crack and bleed like he was possessed. His body jerked and swayed with the motions as if he was being puppeteered by invisible hands. The passion in the man's eyes burned so fiercely that Katsuki wondered what it was.

"Oi. What song are you playing?" Katsuki asked loudly.

The smaller boy perked up and elbowed him in the side. Katsuki hissed and pouted, and his friend shook his head disapprovingly at him.

"Kacchan! Don't interrupt it's *rude*—"

But the violinist stopped.

Both boys froze at the sudden screeching of disharmonious strings and turned towards the elderly man.

There was an indescribable look he was giving them with his weighted down wrinkles. He reminded young Katsuki of what he thought zombies should look like. Frail but somehow still defying the odds. Then the man's chapped lips cracked a grin and the corners of his eyes wrinkled with happy smile lines. The snagged teeth in his mouth showed proudly with all their cavities.

"I was wondering when my two biggest fans would ask what I'm playing," the violinist snickered. "I was beginning to think you two would never ask."

Both boys balked.

"It's called, The Dance of the Love Birds," the violinist said proudly. "I composed it myself! It's one of a kind."

"You made that song?" The smaller boy said with stars in his eyes.

"That's so cool," Katsuki said astonished. "You're a genius."

Katsuki's eyebrows shot up at the idea of someone that talented. This crazy old man made music *and* he played like a professional—that was so amazing!

But then Katsuki stopped and wondered a bit. He glanced up and down at the man's tattered clothes and assessed the holes that were scattered throughout them. Katsuki resisted frowning

because why was the man out on the streets if he was so talented? He belonged playing in a fancy orchestra. He should be world renowned and rich.

“I sure did make this song!” The violinist said with humor in his voice. His smile flattered a bit as his eyes glazed over a bit in thought. Katsuki watched how his hands started to shake a bit. “I-I made it for m-my wife and I for our wedding. S-She’s gone now...but I-I think of her when I play it. I play it...and play it. That way, I can always think of her.”

Katsuki’s heart hurt for the man.

There was a tear that streamed down the violinist’s face, catching in the folds of skin as it rolled down. The elderly man smiled in a way that felt mournful.

“It’s my life’s mission to perfect it,” he continued. “The beginning is the wedding song I originally composed, but I realized it was incomplete when I understood there was more to love than sweetness. There’s hurt. And pain and *betrayal*—” he hissed the last word. “—There’s anguish and there’s mourning. I-I feel like no one makes songs that capture it all! So, I have to!” He finished, sounding a bit desperate at the end.

Katsuki watched how the elderly man nodded his head rapidly. He stared at them like they were the only ones to understand.

“I-I have to do it. I *have* to,” the violinist whispered, slightly crazed.

“I believe you can,” The boy with green eyes said with a gentle smile. “It’s so beautiful already.”

The violinist’s gaze focused back and there was a little bit of hope planted inside of his brown eyes. He stared at the smaller boy as if he had been in the desert for years dying of thirst and the boy had given him his first drink of water.

“Y-You really think so, little one?” He asked slowly. “You think I can make it complete?”

The smaller boy swung his legs and nodded his head with a big grin. “I do!”

“I do too,” Katsuki added. He smiled at the man and gave a thumbs up.

“Thank you both,” the violinist said. More tears started pouring down the man’s face. “You have no idea how much it means to hear that you like it! No one else in my life believed in me. They all told me I had gone *mad* for focusing on the music so much, but they didn’t *understand*! They didn’t understand what a calling felt like! It *eats* you from the inside until you can let it out.”

The man’s shaky hand clutched at his heart to emphasize his point.

“What’s your calling?” Katsuki asked curiously.

“My calling is that I want to create something beautiful,” he said as though it was a secret. “Something that would never leave someone. I want it to imprint on their hearts and in their minds so whenever they hear this melody, they will remember where they were when they

first heard it. They will smile, look towards the one they love and be reminded of all the gorgeous reasons to live."

Katsuki never forgot the speech he heard that spring.

That part of his memory stood out as it was wrapped in the haunting melody of violins.

The rest of that spring and the following months, the two boys continued to be the man's private audience. The violinist asked them what they liked about his composition and what they didn't. The boy with green eyes talked about the beat being too slow but Katsuki said some parts didn't match. The man eagerly took the feedback and adjusted accordingly every time.

It was a cycle after that.

Listen. Critique. Re-compose. Listen once more.

After a while, 'The Dance of the Love Birds' ended up being Katsuki's favorite song.

The pair of young boys ended up finding a love for violin music in that way as they helped the man perfect his song. Katsuki started to imagine himself making music and composing songs for people to play. In his young imagination, he saw him and his best friend possibly going to one of those fancy concerts together. They could listen to people play on pianos, violins, and such together. They could even hold hands and all that stuff while listening to the pretty songs!

It would be perfect.

The elderly violinist was so happy to have company for the first time in decades that he started teaching the young boys the words he muttered.

Da Capo. Duet. Enharmonic. Lento. Adagio.

All the once foreign sounding words had new meanings as Katsuki soaked them up. He eagerly learned everything he was handed, since this was probably the closest thing he'd come to school until his mom returned.

It was the happiest spring that Katsuki could think of.

His heart fluttered every time he hummed the unique melody they helped the man craft.

☽ ☽ ☽

The months passed by without his mother, and Katsuki was beginning to contemplate if she was either dead or gone elsewhere.

He and his best friend found themselves exploring the city together more during the hours the other boy would visit. They wandered freely with young hearts and cheerful laughs. Katsuki watched joyfully as dark curls bounced in the spring breeze with his friend's skipping. Green

eyes would gaze up at him like he was the best person in the world, and it made Katsuki's heart full.

Some days they huddled in the corner of the comic bookstore together. The two boys snickered and laughed while thumbing through the pages. They did everything together to the point Katsuki was looking forward to spending time with the green-eyed boy more than searching for his mother. The sun bright smile of the other boy lit up his life as they explored the city hand in hand.

He didn't find himself counting the days he had been without his mother anymore as long as green eyes were looking at him. The short spring sunlight started to extend in a telltale sign that summer was peaking around the corner. Gorgeous pink blossoms bloomed on the trees and littered in the other boy's curls like confetti.

Time blew by Katsuki quickly with the smaller hand wrapped in his.

Then, it came to halt one day outside of a television store.

He had been passing by the store looking forward to going back to the plaza. The news was playing like always on all the tiny TV screens that were stacked high like Legos. He usually never bothered glancing at the window, but when he did this morning, it made him freeze when he saw the date.

April 19th.

It was the day before his birthday.

There was a level of unnerving shock that settled into him from seeing those numbers on the screen. He will be turning eight *tomorrow*. He'll be eight tomorrow and his mother was still nowhere to be seen.

His heart went from fluttering in anticipation to see his best friend to humming low at the reminder his mother was still missing. He wrinkled his nose as he tried to will away a dark feeling that scratched in the back of mind. He pondered that she might be dead because there was no way she would have left him this long.

But part of him had a fear.

He feared that maybe she really was alive—and that he wasn't that important anymore.

He glanced down at his new sandals that his best friend had brought for him.

☽ ☽ ☽

"Let's go somewhere tomorrow," Katsuki proposed later that day.

The two boys were currently playing in their favorite park. They were fighting with sticks as if they were swords. The violinist had encouraged them to go out and enjoy the weather as he adjusted the song based on their critiques. The elder man had somewhat functioned as a

dysfunctional adult for them as he watched over them the best he could in his slightly unhinged mental state.

“Somewhere like where?” The boy with green eyes asked. He giggled while blocking the blows from Katsuki. He gave three jabs to Katsuki’s stomach that made the taller boy laugh.

“Like, Saitama,” Katsuki said quietly. “They have pretty parks and good food.”

The smaller boy froze mid-swing. His sudden hesitation let Katsuki, who was already in motion, hit him in the neck with the blunt end of the stick. The blond boy paused too and nervously lowered the wooden stick in his hands.

“Saitama?” His friend echoed. His brows furrowed in worry, and he looked at Katsuki unsure. “Th-That’s kind of far, Kacchan.”

“I know, but I always wanted to go,” Katsuki muttered. He kicked the grass a bit and shrugged his shoulders. “My mom said we would go there one day for a carnival, but she...never took me. It’s okay if you don’t wanna go. I figured maybe we could explore more outside of where we live.”

“I dunno,” his friend said wearily. “I have to make sure I’m walking home at—”

“—At 22:22. I know, I know,” Katsuki said grumpily. He probed the end of his stick into the ground a little aggressively. “Never mind. I thought we could do something for my birthday tomorrow. But we can find something around here to do.”

“Wait,” his best friend said curiously. His eyes lit up and Katsuki averted his gaze when he blushed. “I-It’s your birthday tomorrow, Kacchan?”

“Yeah, my birthday is April 20th,” Katsuki muttered. He glanced around at the other people in the park and pursed his lips. “Maybe we can have a picnic here or look to see when a carnival happens in Tokyo—”

“—Let’s go,” his best friend suddenly said.

The smaller boy stepped forward and surprised Katsuki at the sudden change of mind. His friend looked at him with those big green eyes, eager to please. Katsuki felt his heart squeeze, but he glanced at the tiny yellow watch on the other boy’s wrist.

“Are you sure?” Katsuki mulled over. “We don’t have to if you’re gonna get in trouble for coming home late. I'd be happy if we stayed here too.”

“No, let’s go to Saitama! We just have to make sure we’re back in enough time, right? It should be simple.”

“Yeah,” Katsuki agreed. He smiled with all of his teeth and swiftly felt equally as enthusiastic. “It should be simple.”

There was a twinge of fear in pretty green eyes, but ultimately deep resolve took root. A bright grin spread across the other boy’s features as he punched his small fist high to the air.

“Let’s give you a good birthday, Kacchan!”

☽ ☽ ☽

It rained cats and dogs on his birthday.

Katsuki thought at first that it would derail everything. He remembered how he stared at the large stained-glass windows of the abandoned church that morning. They didn’t shine in the magical way they usually did with the grey clouds outside. There were no glittering sparkles of pinks, purples and blues dancing all around. Only grey.

The banging of the rain against the hollow building sounded ominous like a warning for him to stay inside. He started thinking over all the things they could do inside. Play tag. Puppet shadows again maybe, he could pretend to be All-Might this time or they could go bother the old man in the plaza for one of his looney stories.

But maybe with the rain, his friend wouldn’t come.

However, the boy with green eyes showed up right on time.

The smaller boy had come dressed in a yellow rain jacket and had a red umbrella over his head. His smile was bright as though it wasn’t storming outside. In his other hand was his usual plastic bag, and this time it was filled with an extra rain jacket and food like always.

Katsuki realized that day he could always count on his friend and his attachment grew a bit stronger.

They boarded the train easily, paying for the tickets with the yen his friend conjured up from thin air. Katsuki didn’t question it anymore. The money. The food. The clothes. Somehow, the smaller boy always seemed to have the right thing they needed to have a good day.

They arrived in Saitama holding hands and acted as if the sky was full of sun.

It was possibly the best birthday Katsuki had ever had thus far.

Usually, his birthdays before that were spent with his parents. From what he could remember, the ones with his dad were always fun. His parents were merry, smiled, and held him up to blow out the candles on his cake. They happily kissed afterwards and then sandwiched him between another kiss on both of his cheeks as he giggled.

But his seventh birthday was spent with his mother who was weeping.

She tried to smile through her tears, but he could tell it was hard. His dad had passed that year and the emptiness in the house was tenfold. All the radiance his father possessed left with him that year and in his absence, two broken spirits tried to mend without him. The candles on Katsuki’s cake didn’t get blown out that year. The wax melted into the frosting as he hugged his mother for as long as he could.

But this time, he had a friend. The best friend in the world.

His best friend held his hand as they splashed through puddles. The smaller boy eagerly pulled him along as they explored a whole new part of the country. The pretty pink blossoms above them acted like raindrops of their own as they fell down on top of their umbrellas. Katsuki watched, mesmerized slightly, as his friend's pretty dark curls bounced with every hop they did into a new puddle.

Sweet green eyes then turned to him and smiled brightly.

"I'm so happy we're friends, Kacchan!"

Katsuki smiled so hard his cheeks hurt. "I'm happy we're friends too, Izuku!"

The rest of the day was spent looking around the new city. They purchased street food, looked at the parks, and splashed in the rain. They even were able to get bowls of spicy ramen and his best friend sang 'Happy Birthday' to him with his little voice that had a lisp.

Everything had been perfect for Katsuki.

Or more so, it had been perfect until the storm picked up.

The winds became increasingly fierce to the point people on the streets were forced to take cover. Huddles of crowds stood inside the little shelter the overheads of some stores provided. Others waited inside as the sky angrily rained down on the land.

The two boys found themselves in a 7/11 pressed against a window with a large crowd of people. Both of them were looking up at the sky through the foggy glass waiting for the rain to stop.

But it seemed like it wasn't going to. The boy with green eyes nervously checked his little yellow watch. 20:45.

Katsuki bit his lip, undeniably feeling guilty. He told himself that they would make it back for the train. All they needed to do was board the 21:30 train to make it to where they lived in Tokyo at 22:00. That would give his best friend enough time to get home—or at least that was their plan.

The sky above had other ideas as it rained harder. Then it was announced on the tiny television in the 7/11 that all trains were halted until the storm died down.

The next train would run at 22:30.

☽ ☽ ☽

His friend was trying to smile. When they finally boarded the train that night, the boy with green eyes was gazing at him through his sadness. Katsuki could tell he was holding back tears and his small hands were resisting tremors. The guilt chewed through Katsuki's chest because how could they be so *stupid*. They should've just stayed inside the church playing with comics—or anything else.

But his friend had a family who loved him, right? Surely, they would understand. Kids make mistakes sometimes, that's why they had adults.

When they got back to their part of Tokyo, Katsuki expected his friend to speed off. But instead, the other boy took his hand and walked with him back to the abandoned church. He looked down at the little yellow watch and it read 23:15.

His best friend tucked him in that night like he always did, and the smaller boy gave him a taut smile. There were clusters of tears on the rims of his eyes and Katsuki felt his heart snap in two at the sight.

"Did you have a good birthday?" His friend's small voice forced out, clearly holding back emotion.

"I did," Katsuki said sadly. "It was the best birthday I ever had. But please don't cry, I'm sorry. I'm sure you won't get in that much trouble. Ju-Just explain that you got lost in the storm! They should be happy you made it home!"

His friend laughed and quickly wiped his tears away before they could fall. Katsuki didn't know what was funny, but he made sure to give his best friend a tight hug. His friend's arm wrapped around him tightly, and he buried his face in Katsuki's neck. Katsuki could sense that there was more emotion filled in this hug as they squeezed each other.

He almost didn't like it—it nearly felt like a goodbye.

"Th-Thank you for being so kind, Kacchan."

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki waited in the plaza the next day.

He watched as the sky turned the pretty, orange pastel color that usually told him his best friend should be on his way. But as Katsuki waited and waited, the smaller boy never arrived.

He sat patiently like he always did. However, when nightfell came, he acted. Katsuki searched around a little bit worried. He called out the other boy's name with a twinge of fear. This was the first time he spent time searching for two people. He looked for his mom that morning and he searched for his missing best friend that night.

When he could find neither a piece of his heart splintered in half like worn down wood. He bit his lip to keep it from quivering. But the fear that his only friend was never coming back sunk deep into him like a sharp spear.

He imagined what happened: His friend coming home late, and his parents worried over him. Maybe they were worry-warts who fussed a lot too. The other boy fussed and cried at everything, he had to get that from *somewhere*. Maybe his best friend confessed to hanging out with a homeless kid and they freaked out like parents do. Maybe his parents forbade him from coming back out and made him stay inside.

It made Katsuki distraught to think about more than he thought it would.

He didn't want to be separated from his friend. He didn't.

He stayed there all night, listening to the violinist by himself. With every new footstep he turned his head, but every time it was a person who didn't have green eyes. Katsuki felt his bottom lip quiver until he bit back a sob.

He cried softly that day on the bench and his best friend never came to tuck him in.

☽ ☽ ☽

The next day, it was the same thing.

Katsuki's eyes were puffy as he stared down at the pavement in front of the violinist. His chest felt like a million tears were gathered inside, wanting to violently burst out as the pressure on his heart hurt. He cried softly into his hands when the ugly heaviness inside of his body became too much. He wondered if this was it and this was truly where he would be left alone in the world. No mom. No friend. No more food. Just him alone, in that abandoned church.

"Where's your friend, little one?" The violinist finally asked on the second day of Katsuki's friend's absence.

Katsuki stopped crying long enough to look up and wipe the tears and snot from his face.

"I-I don't know," Katsuki admitted, distressed. His voice cracked as he thought about being abandoned a second time. "He—He got home late the other day and I think he's in trouble. B-But he always comes. *Always*. I-I don't even know where he lives so I can go see him."

He worried deeply that this was the end and his young mind spiraled.

"That's no good," the violinist said in a serious tone. "You two are best friends. I can sense you're supposed to be together; it's fated! You have to find him otherwise only sorrow will happen when you're apart. You know, there's a saying about love birds. When one dies, the other fades away too. It gives up so it can be with its other half."

Katsuki frowned immediately. What did that have to do with anything?

Sometimes he forgot that the violinist wasn't exactly in his right mind until moments like this. The man rambled and switched topics so quickly it gave young Katsuki mental whiplash.

He watched as the elderly man ran his hands through his snow-white hair. His brown eyes gave Katsuki a serious look as he continued rambling.

"Wh-When my wife passed, I didn't die, but a part of me did," the violinist confessed. "Some say my sanity died. Others say my mind left me—but really it was my heart. It's hard to imagine a world without her, so I stay with her by playing my song and perfecting it."

"Stay with her?"

Katsuki scrunched his nose but slowly an idea blossomed. His face laxed into an expression of realization as he processed the words. He looked at the platinum ring on the withered hand of the violinist.

“Mhm, yes!” The violinist chuckled. “She’s always with me when I play this violin. My sweetheart is always by my side. With this violin she is always here.”

Out of all the things the violinist said, Katsuki took away one word: *stay*.

He clung to it as tightly as his fear of abandonment clung to him.

He thought about his parents and how they were always together until his dad died. His mom was always joyful and smiling up until that moment. And now, even this crazy old man had a wife who loved him until her dying breath. The violinist was clearly happy until that tragic moment in his life occurred.

Like jamming puzzle pieces together, Katsuki’s young mind made his new revelation fit as he forcefully connected the dots. His mom and the violinist were happy because they had people who loved them and people who *stayed*. People who didn’t *leave*.

Fueled by the terror of abandonment, Katsuki’s young mind focused on the one thing his parents and the violinist had in common.

He stared a little too hard at the shiny ring on the violinist’s fingers.

“How—How does marriage work?” Katsuki finally asked.

The violinist stopped playing. His brown eyes looked baffled as he glanced at Katsuki. “Um. Why, little one?”

“I just wanna know,” Katsuki said casually. He curled his fists into balls on his lap and leaned in tentatively. “I know what it *is,* but I want to know how it *works*. If you get married does that mean the person stays with you?”

“It does,” the violinist said. A distant smile tugged on his chapped lips as he was swept away in a far-off memory. Katsuki had no doubt he was thinking of his late wife as a look of lost love shone in his eyes. “They get to always stay with you. Until death do you part.”

They always stay with you.

Katsuki looked at the elderly man seriously.

“Tell me. How do people get married?”

☽ ☽ ☽

The next day Katsuki waited with the violinist in the plaza for the boy with green eyes.

Katsuki was nervously clutching a bundle of weeds and flowers. He had found them in the park and was holding two makeshift rings made of brown string that knotted into a neat bow

at the top. He had spent all night listening to the violinist ramble on and on about marriage and why it was a good thing.

Usually, Katsuki didn't think about crushes or anything of the sort. Love was weird to him.

That was stuff that didn't make sense, and he had to focus on helping his mom. She needed his undivided attention, so he couldn't worry about stuff like that. Plus, he wasn't even around other kids long enough to care anymore. When he was in school, he thought everyone had cooties anyways.

Anytime he watched his parents kiss he went 'ew' loudly and made a disgusted face. But he didn't have to do anything like that if he didn't want to. He only cared about convincing his friend to marry him so they could *stay* together. Then the other boy's parents would have to understand. That would mean no more missed days. Right?

He—He just wanted the boy with green eyes to *stay* with him. That way he wouldn't be...lonely.

So, Katsuki awkwardly sat there in the plaza, wishing with all his might for the other boy to show up. He wished harder than anything he could imagine as he watched the passing clouds in the sky.

Then like a magical miracle, his best friend came right on time.

Katsuki's heart flew out of his chest at the sight of dark curls and green eyes—but his heart stopped beating when he fully took in his friend's appearance.

There was a white cast on the other boy's left arm, and it was sitting perched in a blue sling. The smaller boy's bottom lip was split with a scab on it and there was a tiny, purple bruise on his upper right cheek. Directly beneath his green eyes.

Katsuki dropped the makeshift bouquet of weeds and the string rings onto the bench, forgotten.

He was given a sad smile as his friend approached him with his plastic bag on the other hand, full of food.

"H-Hi, Ka-Kacchan," his friend said in a hoarse voice. "I-I'm sorry about not coming. I brought you some food though! So, it'll be okay now."

"What happened to your arm?" Katsuki immediately asked. He ignored the food in the bag, focusing on how mortified he was by the bruises. Bruises that were almost everywhere. "And your *face*?"

He didn't even care about the slight hunger in his stomach as he looked at the ugly yellow and purple spotted discolorations. The closer he got on his friend, he could see odd scrapes and cuts littering his arms. He grabbed him by his non-casted arm and pulled him close, ignoring how the smaller boy clearly winced.

His damn brother. Katsuki thought. His nostrils flared in rage. *This had to be his stupid big brother.*

“I-I fell that’s all, Kacchan—”

“—You’re fucking lying,” Katsuki spat harshly. His scarlet eyes burned into watery green ones. “I can tell you’re lying again. You didn’t fucking *fall*.”

His friend flinched at the harsh language being directed at him.

“I…I don’t s’want to talk about it,” the smaller boy whispered. He snatched his arm from Katsuki’s grasp and stepped backwards. He held up the plastic bag, clearly a diversion from his own issues. “Let’s go back to your room. Ca-Can we play and read the new All Might comic?”

Katsuki glared hard, clearly wanting to push the issue. He wanted to puff his chest out and demand his friend show him where the *hell* his brother was at so he could beat him up for this. But the longer those big puppy-like eyes stared at him, Katsuki let his anger be swept away for another day.

He grumbled as he took his friend’s hand, grabbed the bundle of flowers, and improvised rings.

“Okay, we can go back to my room.”

The boy with green eyes smiled.

☽ ☽ ☽

They sat in the small nook on the soft pad of blanket layers.

It smelled like scented roses from the candles and dust a bit but neither boy cared. Katsuki had put down the bundle of forgotten flowers and the two little rings in the corner by his pillow. His friend pulled out the newest All Might comic from his plastic bag.

The pair huddled together, wrapped in a blanket snuggly. Above them, the candles were lit with flickering orange flames on the shelves, and in their hands were flashlights as they read through the pages. The smaller boy was leaning heavily on Katsuki, resting his head on the taller boy’s shoulder. As they flipped through the pages, Katsuki let the other boy teach him words he didn’t recognize.

It was then that Katsuki realized he was falling behind in reading. He could barely pronounce some of the longer, more complicated words without his cheeks pinkening from embarrassment. But his friend was patient and helped him sound out each one.

“Do you like school?” Katsuki asked quietly when they finished the comic. He closed the booklet and turned to look at his friend. “I miss it a lot. I used to be the best in my class, y’know.”

“I like learning,” his friend replied softly. His green eyes stayed trained on the comic cover in front of them. His small finger traced the outline of the cape on the cover. “But my class is full of mean people, and no one really likes me. I would rather stay here with you than go to school.”

Katsuki perked up hearing that word: *stay*.

“You want to stay here with me?” He echoed.

He turned slightly to his friend with wide eyes, and his heart fluttered like a flock of sparrows. His friend smiled the best he could with his busted lip.

“Of course, I do. You’re my best friend, Kacchan.”

“Then...Then marry me,” Katsuki said suddenly.

His friend reeled back, staring at him baffled and Katsuki hastily turned towards his pillow. He quickly grabbed the two strings and the bundle of flowers. The young blond awkwardly stared at his friend for a moment trying to remember all the stupid, weird things the violinist told him about how to marry someone. Give them flowers, kiss them, and then say something like ‘I do’?

Katsuki cleared his throat and pushed the flowers in the other boy’s face. His friend stared at them like he didn’t understand what was happening.

“What is marry?” The boy with green eyes said, tilting his head.

This time it was Katsuki’s turn to be puzzled. “Marriage, like your parents.”

“Like my parents?” His friend stuttered and blinked rapidly. He shook his head and his un-casted hand nervously pulled at the blanket underneath them. “Kacchan. I don’t know what marriage means.”

“It’s when two people like each other a whole lot. They will get married and have babies,” Katsuki explained slowly. He gestured between them. “Like me and you. We’re the babies our parents had.”

His friend stared at him blankly.

“Don’t your parents kiss and all the junk?” Katsuki questioned slowly. He was surprised to come across a word his best friend didn’t know. Usually, the other boy was such a nerd that he was always shoving new words down Katsuki’s throat. “You know, hand holding, saying ‘I love you’ and being super icky with each other? That’s marriage.”

His friend scrunched his nose. “They don’t do any of that.”

“Well, that’s okay,” Katsuki said, shrugging it off. He cleared his throat again and pushed the flowers into his friend’s hand. “When people are married, they stay together. Forever. They get to spend *all* their time together.”

“Really?” His friend perked up. “S-So if we get married, I get to spend all my time with Kacchan?”

“Yup!” Katsuki grinned wide. “We can spend all the time in the world together. B-But most importantly it means we always have to be together, okay? It means we *always* come back to each other—or at least that’s what the old man told me.”

Green eyes sparkled in a way that reminded Katsuki of the glittering night sky.

“I-I like that, Kacchan! How do we get married?”

“We have to wear these rings and kiss to seal the deal,” Katsuki said. “It’ll make it official.”

He scrunched his nose a bit at the end statement. From what the violinist said, everyone who got married kissed after putting rings on each other.

Katsuki held up the fabric rings and told his friend word for word what the violinist had rambled on to him about. The smaller boy nodded, and with every sentence his little smile widened. There was a pink blush on his cheeks as he took in the new concept of ‘marriage’ into his brain that made him giggle and squirm.

His best friend then asked what ‘romance’ was and Katsuki embarrassedly explained. Green eyes grew even bigger at that, and the smaller boy let out a tiny ‘wow’ upon hearing how much two people could love each other.

Katsuki held out his hand for his friend to tie the fabric ring around his finger. The smaller boy was eager. Katsuki watched as he wrapped it twice and tied a bow on it. Then next, his friend held out his hand. Katsuki wrapped it thrice and tied a pretty bow on the top for his friend. The blond boy took the other’s hand in his and they both blushed.

Silence dropped for a second. They looked at each other nervously and scooted in close under the candlelight.

Katsuki gulped as his friend fluttered his eyes closed and pursed his lips. He studied the way his friend’s face flushed pink under the yellow-orange light and the heat in the small nook felt extremely high. Katsuki sucked in a breath and quickly leaned in. They exchanged a quick peck on the lips.

They pulled back and Katsuki was sure he was the color of the sakura blossoms outside. His friend was staring at him with wide eyes, holding onto his hand tightly. There was a new spark in green eyes as he stared at the other boy. A new spark was in red ones too. Katsuki began to wonder if crushes were all that bad anymore.

Katsuki felt himself gradually smile as he looked down at their hands. He liked the way the matching strings on their fingers locked together.

“Now we’re husbands and you always have to come back to me,” Katsuki said. He looked seriously at his best friend. “Alright? You gotta promise.”

His friend nodded eagerly. “Okay, Kacchan. I’ll always come back. I promise.”

“A-And if you want, you could stay here,” Katsuki whispered desperately. He tightened his grip on the smaller hand to the point it made the other boy slightly wince. “I know your big brother is hurting you. If your parents aren’t stopping him, then you should stay here—*with me*. I won’t ever hurt you. I’ll protect you from all of that.”

“I-I—” The smaller boy stuttered over his lisp. “I don’t know if I can do that. I still have to go to school and stuff and check in—”

“—You don’t even like school,” Katsuki pushed. “You said the other kids are mean to you. Then your brother broke your arm. Why not just stay with me?”

Katsuki looked at his friend with a new light in his eye. His mom wasn’t here but he had a new person—*this* person. This sweet, kind person with beautiful green eyes. He gave a lopsided smile that was hinged purely on hope as he continued to explain.

“My mom isn’t coming back. I don’t think she is any more,” Katsuki said finally.

His chest hurt and it felt like a nail was being driven into his sternum at the admission. He didn’t like the fact, but it was a reality he had to accept. She missed his birthday, and if that was any indicator, then that meant he was alone. He saw that ghost visual of his mother smiling fading in his mind. Her red eyes were dull, and the smile was no more. The phantom of her disappeared into the background with the thick crowd of Tokyo never to be seen again.

His best friend looked at him sadly.

“I think she’s dead—or she forgot about me,” Katsuki finished. He cusped the smaller hand between his and nodded devotedly. “But since we’re married now, we could move away. The two of us. We could find another empty building and live in it together, somewhere warm where we don’t have to worry about the winter. We can be happy and married.”

“Really?” His friend whispered. He stared at Katsuki with an inkling of hope. He leaned in and this near Katsuki could see all those horrible scratches, cuts, and bruises on his skin. “J-Just the two of us?”

“Mhm,” Katsuki confirmed with a hum. He beamed at the spark of his future shifting to something brighter. “We have to prepare. If you could, we should save up more money and clothes. Get those big suitcases the grown-ups always have. The fancy ones with wheels.”

“I can do that,” His friend nodded. “I-It might take a while for me to get lots of money, but we can start to save it!”

Katsuki grinned wide and the tears caught on the rims of his eyes.

His friend laughed happily, and small tears formed in his eyes as they held hands in the tiny nook.

☽ ☽ ☽

The rest of the spring went on without another incident.

The boy with green eyes came back every day much to Katsuki's delight. Then the violinist was overjoyed when they told him they got married. The elder man had laughed and chuckled so hard Katsuki was sure one of his loose teeth was going to fly out. He played *The Dance of The Love Birds* for them in the plaza as the two boys danced under the forgotten statue of the angel above.

Every day his best friend brought a tiny handful of yen. It wasn't much, but it was something.

They stocked up clothes and food in the tiny nook along with comics as the small area began to look like a home. There was part of Katsuki that didn't want to part with it, but if it meant he and his best friend would be away from that stupid big brother, then so be it. They would find a better home with maybe even a bigger room.

The two young boys watched the changing seasons go by easily. The bright spring blossomed into a vibrant summer, and everything was faultless to young Katsuki.

They celebrated his best friend's birthday in the plaza happily. They didn't want to make the mistake of what they did on Katsuki's birthday.

The violinist used some of the yen he got from his street performances to buy them a chocolate cake, birthday hats, and pretty sparklers. All three of them sat in the plaza under the statue of the angel eating the dessert and singing happy birthday for his best friend. Katsuki learned that day, his friend apparently didn't celebrate his birthday. It wasn't something his family did.

The mere thought of that made Katsuki upset because what type of parents *did* his friend have?

But whenever he asked, his best friend grew quiet about it.

So, Katsuki avoided asking. He wanted them to stay happy and smiling. They had a whole future together and stupid parents were no longer going to be a problem. He held his best friend's hand with visions of their future dancing around in his head that year.

If this was marriage, Katsuki loved it. Especially when pretty green eyes would stare at him, and his best friend would give him a peck on the cheek.

Soon after that, vibrant summer fell into crisp autumn.

His best friend's arm eventually healed and Katsuki felt like they almost had enough money to buy several train tickets to go far away. They picked out a place one day with the map Katsuki had stolen from one of the 7/11s nearby. In his room that night, the two boys settled for a random town that was far south.

It looked far away enough that it would be sunny, awesome, and right near beaches. Naga, Okinawa. He had no clue how they'd get there, but with just the two of them, they would.

“I'm so excited to go live in the sunny place!” His friend said brightly after daydreaming about their escape.

Katsuki was too. The Sunny Place was going to their safe spot, and no long would winter eat away at him. Katsuki contemplated if he could get a job and he could take care of his friend to repay him for all the kindness he bestowed on him.

They set a date to leave right when crisp autumn would shiver into winter.

It had almost been a full year without his mother now, and Katsuki had stopped searching for her when the first snowfall happened.

He no longer went to her favorite store. No longer wandered by her favorite park. He avoided all her favorite restaurants and focused solely on his best friend. He forced all his thoughts to stay on track towards the new future he was building because if he strayed too long on his mother—he worried.

In recent days, he had settled on the notion she had died.

Part of him leaned towards this theory to spare his feelings, even though it hurt about the same. His imagination was cruel, and he could vividly see her in a ditch somewhere and forgotten. Even in his mind he could smell the rotten flesh and picture how her eyes were rolled back and sunken. When he thought about her too long, he could see her decaying away.

So, he avoided searching for her anymore. He couldn’t think about her without feeling nauseous.

But he had his new husband and his new husband had him.

However, two days before they were supposed to leave, things flipped upside down.

His best friend had come to the nook that night with excitement in his pretty green eyes. He was holding a poster that had colorful letterings and pictures on it. It had pretty people dressed in bright clothes jumping through hoops and a lion on the front.

“Kacchan! There’s a carnival in town!” His friend exclaimed. He grinned wide and held up the poster close to the blond boy’s face. “Th-There’s going to be big roller coasters and a Ferris wheel and everything! But the best part is that it’s *free*!”

Katsuki took the poster from his friend’s hand and scrutinized the paper. “A carnival? A real one?”

“Mhm! You said you always wanted to go to one!” His friend cheered. He jumped up and down on the mess of blankets and pillows. “We can go to the carnival, have fun and then come back here right before bedtime. Th-There’s even going to an All Might guy there, and he can sign our comics for us!”

Katsuki perked up. “All Might? What?!”

His best friend nodded furiously with his gapped teeth. “Yes! We could see All Might, Kacchan. *All Might*!”

Katsuki looked up at the big poster on the side of the wall in his small makeshift room. He saw the tall figure posed with his hands on his hips and his cape in the wind. Katsuki sucked in an excited breath and looked at his best friend with a toothy grin.

“Okay! Let’s go to it. I always wanted to go to a carnival!”

☽ ☽ ☽

The day came for the carnival and Katsuki hummed his favorite song to himself.

He sang all the high notes and low swings in *The Dance of the Love Birds*. By now, he memorized the melody by heart. He was sure his best friend knew it by heart too.

Katsuki got dressed that evening, thinking happily about how he was finally doing all the things his mom promised they would do. First his best friend took him to Saitama and now they were going to a carnival. He blissfully daydreamed about where else he and his new husband would go.

He organized all his stuff and took a good look around the nook.

A pang of sullenness settled into him as he stared around at his makeshift home. He had a bundle of good memories here, even if they were attached at the root to the pain of being left by his mother. He thought about the violinist in the plaza and how he would even miss that looney old man.

Katsuki glanced at the red suitcase that was thrown off in the corner with his stuff stacked high on top.

His best friend had brought the bag for him to start packing his things. Katsuki had tried, but he didn’t quite want to yet. He was admittedly attached to this dusty old place. He would miss the coziness. He would miss the routine like someone who had gotten used to the poison they were spoon fed. He knew it was not the best way of living, but it was the only stability he had since his mom left him.

Uprooting that gave him unsolicited fear. The only thought that gave Katsuki any peace was looking forward to living with his best friend.

He figured tomorrow they could pack up the nook together just like they had built it together. It would be a fitting way to start their new journey.

Katsuki zipped up his winter jacket that was slightly too tight now and put on his boots. He wrapped himself up in his winter gear as he prepared to go meet his best friend at the carnival. He fiddled with his gloves that were becoming too small as he wandered out into the winter air.

He eagerly walked towards where the carnival was, and it was easy to find.

Loads of people were dressed in their winter clothes happily chatting and talking with one another. Their breaths were like little clouds in the chilly air. The loud sound of distant upbeat music echoed into Katsuki's ears as he drew closer. He could even hear clapping in one direction and cheering from another. The smell of buttery burnt popcorn and sweet carnival food wafted into his nose. He smiled happily as all the families were floating in and out and what looked to be groups of teenagers were all walking to the entrance.

Katsuki found himself waiting there, under the colorful candy cane colored arch.

On the large sign it read 'Japan Traveling Carnival Park' in bright, pink neon colors. The 'C' on the sign flickered and he could hear that electric buzz above him. From where he was, Katsuki could perfectly view the large Ferris wheel and all the fun rides. He grew excited in anticipation as he could hear all the screams and laughter. He smiled as he waited for his best friend to come.

He waited for a while.

Then he waited some more.

Katsuki wearily looked around for a bundle of pretty curly hair. He awkwardly glanced down at the little red watch his friend had gotten him. It was past the time they had said they would meet up. But it was okay. They were married so Katsuki didn't have too much fear about *not* seeing his best friend. Even if something happened, they would always come back to each other.

Then suddenly a big hand reached out and grabbed him by his arm and forced him to turn around.

Katsuki was about to yell, startled but stopped. His voice ran dry like a barren river at the sight of blonde hair and red eyes that matched his. His heart stopped.

"M-Mom?" He whispered. The word was heavy on his tongue.

Mom. It was his mom.

"Hi, sweetie," she said. "I'm back. I'm so sorry that it took so long."

Katsuki's throat clammed up instantly from shock.

Red eyes and blonde hair. Red eyes and blonde hair looking at him like a mirror. Katsuki struggled to make sense of what he was seeing as his eyes started prickling. Gradually, the sounds of the crowd increased in volume in sync with his erratic heart. All the cheering, screaming, and overpowering smells were no longer exciting. Now all the stimulation was drowning out his senses as he started hyperventilating.

The visual of her dead in a ditch with her eyes rotting was now gone.

She was alive.

She had been alive this damn whole *time*.

Katsuki's heart tugged between relief and anger.

"M-Mom. W-What—" What the hell did he even say?

He suddenly heard the sound of a giggle similar to his best friend's and snapped back to his right mind. His head started pounding furiously as he looked around frantically. His best friend. Hi-His best friend. He had to find him first.

Where was he?

Katsuki eyed his mother like she was a ghost. He couldn't do this *now*; his best friend was going to be waiting for him and they were supposed to go away together—why was this happening now? Why did she have to come back when he figured it all out? Why did she leave him? Why didn't she love him enough like his best friend did? Why, why, *why*—

"Katsuki? Katsuki, what's wrong?" His mom asked as if she hadn't been missing for a *year*.

Katsuki shook his head furiously. He snatched his arm away from her in horror and stepped back like her touch burned. He stared with mixed fury and sadness at her yet at the same time he wanted to embrace her.

He didn't know if he wanted to scream or cry—so he did neither.

Gridlocked in a state of confusion in his mind, Katsuki silently gawked at her through watery eyes. Suddenly the happy carnival sounds mimicked buzzing wasps stinging into him and all he wanted was to go back to nook and hide away.

"Katsuki, sweetie, I'm so sorry. I didn't mean to leave you that long," Mitsuki said softly.

She kneeled down and touched his face. He flinched automatically, unsure if he liked it. She let out a sigh and then apologetically cupped his hands.

Katsuki looked at her clothes. Her nice fucking clothes. She even somehow smelled like fancy perfume. Her white sweater was clean, and her earrings and necklace were made of shiny pearls. Her purple coat looked soft to the touch and her hat was fuzzy.

Katsuki looked down at his clothes that were a size too small.

She had left him—this whole time. She had really left him.

His face crumbled and he sobbed.

In the midst of his racing mind, his mother pulled him into an embrace. Familiar warmth wrapped around him, and he hesitantly hugged her back. He gripped onto her as he flashbacked on all the times he had wandered out in the city looking for her. He thought about the endless nights he wished she was safe. And she *was*. She was alive and smelled like rich perfume.

He hugged her tighter and all his tears busted through like a floodgate.

“M-Mom, I missed you,” Katsuki rasped out as he cried. “Why did you leave me here?”

“I know baby, I know, I’m so sorry,” Mitsuki hushed sorrowfully. She gently cradled him and carded her hands through his tangled hair. “I didn’t mean to. I thought it would be quicker, but it’s all better now, okay? I got a place for us. You even have your own room—but we have to go now. W-We can’t stay here too long.”

Katsuki pulled back, confused. “A house?” *A room?* “W-We have to leave *now*?”

Mitsuki gave a strained, urgent smile and nodded. “Yup!” She stood up and forcefully grabbed his hand. Before Katsuki could process it, she was dragging him along in the dense crowd. “But we have to go now, baby—”

“—Wait,” Katsuki said frantically. He planted his feet and yanked his arm back. Both of their bodies jerked and Mitsuki frowned in disapproval. “I-I have a friend. We were supposed to leave for Okinawa together.”

“*Okinawa*?” She stared at him like he was crazy. “Leave *together*? Katsuki, wh-what? You were going to leave when I told you not to go anywhere? With a stranger?”

“You left me!” He hissed in defense and yanked his hand back and hugged it to his pounding chest. “Y-You *left* me. I thought you died like dad did!”

This time Mitsuki’s face softened.

“But I’m here now, sweetie.” She kneeled down again and gazed into her son’s angry, burning eyes. She touched his tear-stained cheer with desperation as she tried her best to calm him down. “You don’t have to worry about all that anymore, but we have to *go*. And we have to go *now* otherwise we’re not going to make it to the nice house and everything.”

Katsuki wearily looked over his shoulder in the dense crowd. He searched for green eyes. Pretty, green, unique eyes. He wearily eyed the time and how it was almost an hour past when they said they were supposed to meet up.

He looked at his mom with apprehensive eyes. “C-Can my best friend come live with us?”

“Who, sweetie?”

“Izuku,” Katsuki said softly. He kept searching but didn’t see the curly head of hair he wanted. “He’s m-my best friend and the same age. He’s meeting me here. We were going to go to the carnival together.”

Mitsuki bit her lip and looked over her shoulder. “O-Okay, we can wait but not for too long, alright? If we don’t see him soon, we can come back and get him.”

Katsuki nodded as they started looking into the crowd.

But with each passing figure, Katsuki’s heart hummed in disappointment. Nobody had green eyes or curly hair.

He glanced at his mom as they waited. She smiled back at him and gently held his hand. It almost didn't feel real. He expected her to be a vivid hallucination and phase through him. But she never did. She gave him a loving kiss on the forehead and detangled his spikes as they waited for his best friend. As she doted on him, slowly all his anger dissolved.

She was here.

She was safe and even though she came back a year later—she did come back. He hesitantly grasped her hand and they waited there. He thought it was strange how his mom looked over her shoulder every few minutes, skittish. At first, he assumed she was keeping her eyes peeled for his friend when Katsuki described to her what he looked like.

But then it became clear she was watching out for someone else.

Another hour passed, making his best friend two hours late.

His mom was officially past antsy.

"O-Okay, Katsuki. We need to leave, otherwise something bad might happen," Mitsuki said a little forcefully. She checked her shiny watch and Katsuki's heart dropped. "We can come back tomorrow and look for your friend, alright? But you have to come with me now."

She stood up and reached out her hand towards him to follow.

Katsuki looked over his shoulder one last time.

Katsuki worried as he thought about his best friend's old, bandaged eye and broken arm. He thought about all those ugly scrapes and bruises that littered his skin. He then realized that they were leaving in two days—but if his mom was here, then maybe she could take them both in. Right? They could share a room and now they had a grown-up to help them. Maybe they didn't need to go all the way to Okinawa.

"Promise we'll come back for Izuku?" He asked in a shaky voice, feeling torn. "H-He needs me too, mom. His brother beats him up."

Mitsuki smiled reassuringly at him. "We'll come back for him. I promise."

Katsuki nodded and grabbed her hand because he believed her.

That was the last time Katsuki believed her and the first of many promises his mother broke.

☽ ☽ ☽

They didn't go back for his best friend and it shattered Katsuki's heart in a million pieces.

When his mother finished whisking him away to another part of the country, she didn't listen to a word he said. She kept saying it was dangerous to go back to Tokyo. Bad men were looking for her and lurking about, but Katsuki didn't fucking *care*.

All he cared about was his best friend and how the smaller boy was somewhere possibly worried about him. She told him the other boy would be fine without him and that he had a family that clearly cared for him. Brothers fought all the time and that a broken bone or busted lip was nothing to cause alarm. She kept trying to explain to Katsuki that she couldn't *take* another child away from a home when she already was trying her best to keep them together.

Katsuki shook his head at the explanation. He frantically explained to his mother that he and his friend were married and that meant they were *supposed* to *always* come back for each other. He lifted his hand to show her the string on his finger—and all the color drained from her face.

Mitsuki was mortified to hear Katsuki say such a thing.

She told him that they were kids. They were only playing make believe and that they weren't *really* married. Katsuki tried to dismiss her and say she was wrong, but she kept repeating it wasn't real. It *wasn't* real. It wasn't *real*.

The words harpooned a section of his young heart that Katsuki didn't expect it to. Hearing that their marriage wasn't authentic was like standing on a glass floor and having it shatter underneath his feet. He felt like he was left free falling as sharp shards cut into him.

Katsuki had a visceral reaction.

He lashed out harshly with curses, yells and he broke everything he could touch out of spite. Mitsuki tried to wrestle him into calming down as he sobbed from the sudden separation in a full-blown tantrum.

After that, his mother kept him inside for a long time. Katsuki cried harshly on the floor of the new home his mother caged him inside of. She didn't enroll him in school right away, saying that things needed time to 'cool off' before they could go back to normal. But Katsuki didn't know what the fuck *normal* was anymore.

Normal for him had been painful hunger.

Normal for him was having body odor bad enough that other people in the streets avoided him.

Normal for him was sleeping in that dark nook hoping the rats didn't get into his food.

Normal for him had been green eyes, a little yellow watch and a kind boy who tucked him in every night.

The searing pain of separation broke through him when he realized he would have none of those things anymore. No violin music. No looney old man to tell him jokes and rant about the stars, fate, and love. No more green eyes. He was torn in a way he never thought he would be. He finally had his mom back—but why couldn't he have his best friend too?

Katsuki gritted his teeth as he looked around at his new normal.

It was a sterile, white apartment. The space was tiny, smaller than the house they lived in with his dad, but it was big enough for two people—maybe even three. His room was decorated in all the All Might things he could imagine with a nice twin sized bed on it.

It was everything Katsuki starved for on his hungriest days.

But somehow it didn't ease the hurt that was crushing him from the inside out.

☽ ☽ ☽

The years passed and his mother kept him under a tight, watchful eye.

She was now mother of the year suddenly. It reminded him of the days his dad was alive.

She smiled, cooked, and went to work like a functional person. She made it a point to drop him off at school every day and pick him up. She forcefully enrolled him in afterschool activities to keep him out of trouble when Katsuki started showing signs of aggression in class.

Then when she learned the aggression stemmed from kids making fun of his reading level, she hired a private tutor on weekends to get him up to speed on the year of schooling he missed.

But despite all this, the older he grew, Katsuki's naivety melted away.

He found out quickly that his mother wasn't supposed to have kept him back when he was seven. She was legally ordered to hand him over to Child Protective Services after being deemed as unfit to raise a child.

She told him the bullshit reason that she left him in that alley was to spin a lie that he ran away. This way, CPS would stop thinking she was still keeping him. She said eventually they gave up, and that was when she came back for him.

There was more to the story though, Katsuki figured.

He dully listened to her when she spun the intricate webs of her excuse. Despite his mother's best efforts to be believable, he could see the holes in her web glaring at him.

Many questions remained unanswered. Such as, where did she go? Who had she been with? Where did she get all the money from to suddenly put them in the countryside? And finally, why had she lost custody of him in the first place?

All these were tiny details his mother never elaborated on, but Katsuki would come to find them out later in life.

She begged for his forgiveness and the opportunity for them to start over. She even begged for him to forget the boy with green eyes.

But at that young age, he couldn't.

☽ ☽ ☽

When he was eight and nine, Katsuki could only think about his best friend.

He imagined going back to Tokyo and tried to find a way to sneak out—but it was impossible. His mother was like a hawk and getting around her was not easy.

At the age of nine, he told some kids at school he was married during White Day and faced the humiliation of everyone in his class laughing at him. They poked fun at the dirty string on his finger and called him names to the point Katsuki lashed out again.

He beat a kid up so badly his mother was called, and he was suspended.

After that incident, his mother forced him to take off his ring and throw it away. She told him no more mentions of marriage and that he was going to stop playing pretend right that instant. It cut so deeply that Katsuki grew bitter at the mention of anything about marriage.

It was *useless* and it didn't work.

He was without his best friend and no one understood that he had to go back to him.

He hated the mention of anything related to romance after that.

☽ ☽ ☽

When he was ten, Katsuki became a loner.

He shot up in his class rankings and his teachers deemed him a bright, promising pupil. Every single one of his teachers doted over him even though he leaned with an interest in music. Specifically, the violin.

Whenever he heard those melodic chords, he thought about what the violinist said about whenever he played that song, his wife was with him. Now, whenever Katsuki heard classical music, his friend was with him.

So, he listened to it all the time.

☽ ☽ ☽

When he was eleven, Katsuki learned his mom slept around with the dads in his class.

He had been waiting outside the school for his mom to get him when a group of extras in his year approached him. He didn't know a single damn one of their names and didn't give a shit to learn. They came up to him jeeringly and used words like 'slut', 'whore', and 'homewrecker' to describe his mom.

One of them mentioned that she deserved to get beat up until she had several broken bones. They all gathered around him, called him street trash, and pointed out his worn down clothes. Seeing those extras point their fingers in his face snapped something violent inside of Katsuki.

Without fail, he found himself lashing out again.

This time it was worse than the outbreaks before. He aggressively wrestled down a boy on the concrete and landed furious punches into his face until there was a sickening crack of a broken nose and jaw.

By the time his mom pulled up to the school that day, it had been a bloodied, hectic mess.

But when they got home, he told her what was said. She froze and stared at him, surprised.

She didn't reprimand him.

His mother quietly iced his bruised knuckles and told him he didn't do anything wrong. Sometimes people deserved to get punched in the mouth. She only critiqued how he went about it: next time, if he was going to humble someone, he should do it in a way that he didn't get in trouble.

Katsuki took that lesson to heart.

The next person that year who spoke ill of his mother found themselves missing teeth, but he was smart enough not to do it at school.

After that, not a damn soul messed with him again.

☽ ☽ ☽

When Katsuki was twelve, he found himself distantly missing having a best friend.

He thought about green eyes a lot and birthdays.

Every year, his mom threw him a lavish birthday party with the two of them since he didn't have any close friends. She bought the biggest cakes and all the comics he could dream of. They sang happy birthday, but at this age he wished he had other friends. However, the extras at his school were too annoying.

On his twelfth birthday, his mom bought him a musical composition book. He had privately told her he wanted to be one of those people who wrote for fancy orchestras. He didn't mention the looney violinist who was his inspiration, keeping that part to himself.

She was thrilled and leaned into his classical music love eagerly. She bought an old vinyl player and gathered classical records for him.

Every day she came home with a new one and Katsuki happily listened.

Now every time Katsuki heard a new song with violins, he thought about the boy with green eyes.

He sadly wondered if the boy still didn't have birthday celebrations.

☽ ☽ ☽

When Katsuki turned thirteen his mother started slipping back into her old ways.

The first crack in her perfect mom demeanor happened suddenly.

She stopped picking him up from school without notice.

Katsuki had waited there for what seemed like an eternity with his heavy schoolbooks. As everyone else went home, it felt a little too familiar. He knew it was just fucking school but that didn't stop the dull ache of abandonment from creeping back on him.

The fear of being left alone again loomed closely behind him like his shadow that evening as he walked home.

It took over an hour to make it to the apartment.

When he had gotten home, she was laid up on their couch with one of his classmate's dads. He recognized the man with salt and pepper hair, who was definitely married. Or maybe he was going through a divorce now. Katsuki truthfully didn't fucking know or care. The young blond's presence wasn't acknowledged as the adults giggled on the couch with glasses full of red wine.

Katsuki bitterly wandered into his room and slammed the door that day.

His mother apologized the next morning and told him that he was big enough to walk to and from school.

So, Katsuki had to start getting up an hour earlier to get to class on time.

The next crack in her perfect mom act came with her absence from home that year.

Unexpectedly, Katsuki found himself alone at home in the mornings, or at nights. And if his mom was home, she had men over who played card games a little too enthusiastically. He learned it was called 'poker' from one of the gruff looking men with a cigar.

A guy with a scar over his eye blew smoke in Katsuki's face as he explained the game.

"You're old enough to know what the fuck gambling is kid!" The man chuckled. Mitsuki laughed too and took a swig of her red wine. Her cheeks were rosy as she looked gleefully at the cards in her hand. "It's fun as hell, boy. You should give it a try."

"No thanks." Katsuki waved his hand to waft away the smoke and scowled. "I'll be in my room if you need me, mom."

"Of course, Katsuki. Have a good night, sweetie!"

He saw his mom lose a lot of money that day and every day she played poker. The greedy men walked in their apartment and left with their cash and the stench of cigars stuck to the walls.

Shortly after this new habit, the number of groceries they had dwindled. They grew thinner and thinner with each month until the only thing in the house was instant noodles and spoiled milk.

His mom made up the excuse that work was paying her less, but Katsuki didn't believe it.

After a while, Katsuki couldn't tell if the hollowness in his core was from loneliness or hunger anymore. His fear of abandonment was looming behind him like his shadow, latched on and whispering insecurities in his ear.

"The problem is you," his self doubt murmured. "You're just not good enough a son for her to be a good mom for."

"She's going to leave you," his anxiety muttered. "One day you'll wake up and be by yourself again."

"You're unlovable," his self-hatred stated bluntly. "Who could ever love someone like you?"

The whispers in his head grew louder everyday.

Then the final crack of her perfect mom act happened when she disappeared for four days. Directly on the anniversary of his dad's death.

The first day Katsuki freaked out. He had gone door to door looking for his mom until sun down. He drew a shabby picture of her to make sure people knew what she looked like. His eyes were slightly crazed, and he gritted his teeth to prevent himself from crying. With every new face he encountered, he was given a sad head shake when he asked if they had seen her.

It made him spiral slightly, alone in that sterile apartment by himself.

He began worrying about things like the bills and the food—were the lights even paid?

What if they were thrown out into the streets again? What if he was going to be left alone in the goddamn cold once more? What if this time he actually got frostbite and died because there would be no boy with green eyes—

Katsuki slept in his closet those nights alone to calm down. The tight space gave him some level of comfort and familiarity.

Then when his mom did come back, she reeked like alcohol and was crying profusely.

She busted through the door on the third night of her absence, nearly terrifying Katsuki. He had whirled towards the door ready to defend himself from an intruder, but instead there was his mother, soaking wet from the rain, sobbing.

Her knees gave out and Katsuki rushed to catch her. She collapsed in his arms and clutched onto him while weeping.

"Masaru," she sobbed. Her voice was hoarse as her nails sunk into him. "My Masaru is never coming back…is he?"

Katsuki froze.

He gazed down at his crying mother in his arms and she looked up at him with the most broken-hearted expression he had never seen. There was a deep woefulness that Katsuki had only seen the violinist have in his eyes when he thought of his late wife. It was uncanny how identical his mother's eyes were to that old man's now.

Suddenly, what his dad said about his mother needing him clicked.

The gears in his head turned when he realized his dad probably knew about his mother's instability with money. He thought back on it, and he remembered how his mother never did work originally. His dad took care of mostly everything as they lived a plush life. Now he was gone, and his mother was struggling to stay afloat.

His dad had been passing him the torch.

Later that evening, Katsuki settled into his role as an emotional support system and pushed down all his own feelings.

Mitsuki began emotionally unloading on him about his dad, wishing that he was here to help her. As Katsuki listened, it felt like she was handing him heavy boulder after heavy boulder as he took on all her anguish.

She let it all spill out: the money problems, her gambling addiction and how she had been off on a gambling spree when he was seven. She even talked about how his dad tried to satisfy her addiction by working extra shifts all the time to keep them afloat.

With each new bit of information, Katsuki felt as though his feet were sinking into quicksand. He realized how dire their situation could and *would* inevitably become.

He stayed up all night with her as she cried on his shoulder. Then when the clock struck midnight, she revealed the single photo she had of the three of them. It was when Katsuki was at least five, and the sun was shining bright. He was sitting on both of his parent's shoulders, reaching high for the sky. They all looked so happy and perfect together.

His mother gave the photograph to Katsuki with a look of motherly love.

"You should have this," Mitsuki said with a weak smile. "This is the only photograph of your father I have left. Hah. Now that I say that out loud, I realized how badly I fucked up. I-I'm sorry for all of this, Katsuki. You deserve better. I'll try to be better again."

It was an empty promise because Katsuki realized she couldn't do better—even if she wanted to.

His mom wiped her tears, not his, and gave him a slack hug before hiding away in her room. That night, Katsuki laid awake in his room and through the walls he could hear her crying.

With a heavy heart, thirteen-year-old Katsuki realized he needed to grow up quicker.

He made the connection that all of his pain stemmed from expecting his mother to take care of him. And the only way to make his pain end was to stop expecting her to. Because at the end of the day, she needed him, not the other way around.

The epiphany made an old, rustic pain resurface.

He glanced up at his All Might posters with a dull feeling. Suddenly all the cravings for the newest toys, games and comics felt silly. It was childish, something he could no longer be if he wanted to survive.

But before Katsuki could let his childhood go, a scratch at the back of his head that year was digging into him to answer an unknown question.

☽ ☽ ☽

One particular day in summer rolled around that year and Katsuki found himself skipping school.

July 15th.

His mom had gone off to work and instead of walking to school, Katsuki walked to the train station. He had money from writing some extra's papers for them. It was exactly enough yen to cover a handful of train rides with no issue.

That morning, Katsuki took three trains that spanned most of the day all the way to Tokyo.

When he stepped off the train that morning, he found himself in a city he barely recognized. The bright neon lights felt brighter and somehow the crowd felt denser. Or maybe possibly he felt more alone.

Over the last five years, things had clearly shifted around. He weaved through the winding crowds and streets like he was navigating a misplaced memory. Sometimes he got the direction right when he recognized a place he used to know. Then other times he felt stuck and lost when he had a clue where he was. It took him nearly an hour to navigate his way back to that lone, forgotten alley where he used to sleep.

When he did find it, no homeless people were gathered.

Instead, frivolous little jewelry stores had been put up. The whole area was bright, commercial, and neon. Weird pop music he never heard played as he looked at the strange new sight. The plaza was fixed up and the cracked forgotten statue of the angel was no longer there—and neither was the violinist. The fountain was running now, nearly overflowing with precious water. Tiny children threw pennies inside and made wishes out loud as he stayed there frozen in shock.

Katsuki felt like a phantom haunting this place.

He sat on the wooden bench where he first met the boy with green eyes with. Scarlet eyes glanced around like the creature of habit he was. He searched for pretty dark curls fruitlessly,

feeling silly. He stared pitifully, hoping to see that boy run around the corner.

"*Kacchan! I'm here now!*" His imagination supplied for him.

He felt himself crumble slightly knowing that voice would probably only ever be in his head now. When two boys playing tag passed him, Katsuki gritted his teeth and got up from the bench.

His heart was beating out of his control as he walked toward where he knew the abandoned church to be. The path was easy to find, he simply followed the cracked and neglected sidewalk to get there. When he came upon his old home, his feet stayed rooted in place.

It was untouched.

It sat there, weathered more by the five brutal years that had passed. The rustic cross on top was broken now, and it seemed like this building was the only piece of his past that remained. Slowly Katsuki followed the pulling in his chest and tried to steady his rocky emotions.

Melancholy, regret, and hurt danced in harmony inside of his chest to make Katsuki a perfect sonata of sadness. It was painful to gaze upon the abandoned building that held so many precious memories.

He walked around the back and pulled back that one wooden board to see the crawl space they used to use. He hunched down to see if possibly he could fit, and when he couldn't the anger swirling inside of him rose.

Katsuki used his foot to kick open the tiny hole and widened it. Pieces of wood flew all over as he let all his unchecked aggression spill into the motion. He kicked and kicked until the weak wood gave under his weight. Katsuki choked back a sob and blinked back burning tears that he didn't quite understand as he forced himself an entrance.

When it was large enough for his new, awkward teenage body, Katsuki hunched down. He found himself crawling in as his body moved like he was possessed.

He stumbled inside, and stood in the same spot he had years ago. He looked up at the stained-glass windows that were now dingier. The sparkling rays of light were duller now as they casted specs of purple, blue, and green onto his sullen face. They no longer shone with the same wonderous glow and in a way, now it felt sad. He eyed all the forgotten, beautiful windows. Especially the large circular one sitting dead center.

Katsuki walked down that dark aisle to the nook in the back. He easily found the small door under the stairs cracked open. He reached for the door but was halted by his memories. He heard all the laughs and giggles that once used to be his favorite sound coming from inside.

"*You're my favorite person, Kacchan,"* his memory whispered. *"My favorite person in the whole world. I hope we can be friends forever."*

Katsuki made a pained face as he forced himself to reach for the cold metallic handle. He opened the nook slowly; the pain in his chest tripled as he eventually fell to his knees. He

made a raw expression when the door was opened all the way and he could see inside the forgotten bit of his childhood.

Sitting inside were all his old things, covered with the dust of neglect.

It was perfectly positioned with how he left it. Suitcase in the corner. Clothes folded and ready to be packed. Messy blankets were everywhere. His All Might figurine was placed next to melted down candles.

Katsuki crawled inside. When he was fully in his old spot, his heart squeezed under all the regret he held as a naïve child who believed his mother's word. He sat there cross legged for a while, knees touching either side of the nook. His head almost hit the top and his bones were aching slightly at the awkward positioning.

Katsuki hated how he was too big; he didn't remember growing up or even feeling it. Yet here he was, larger and now he could no longer afford to be the same child—if he ever was one.

Scarlet eyes looked down where his pillow was and sitting there was a small note, also covered in dust.

He picked up the small, white paper with trembling hands. He read the single line on it that was written in shaky handwriting. He read it over and over until the final bit of his emotions were overcome with agony.

"I love you, Kacchan. Please come back."

With only those two sentences, Katsuki's delicate emotions were crushed, and he wept.

He cried like his soul needed to expel all the heavy emotions weighing him down.

He read the note over and over again, paralyzed in that spot for the rest of the day.

He studied the nook that held his childhood that year and all the posters that were poorly taped up. He wept harder when he stared at the suitcase and wondered about what could've been. He wondered what would've happened if his mother hadn't found him. He wondered what would have happened if his friend had come on time that day.

Would they still be friends? Would they still be happy? Would they have stayed together?

But worst of all, Katsuki wondered how long his forgotten friend had waited for him to come back.

He pictured the tiny boy with green eyes patiently waiting for him until he too outgrew this nook. He imagined an older version of the boy woefully giving up. He could vividly picture the kindness in those viridian irises draining like someone was sucking poison out. His once savior probably casted away the compassion from his body to prevent himself from being disappointed ever again.

He wondered where he was, and if he was alright. The guilt chewed at Katsuki, thinking about the broken bones and bruises. How he had just *left*. There was nothing he could do but hope the boy was safe, and had gone far away from that big brother of his.

But that's all Katsuki could do—hope.

Katsuki pocketed the note as he dried his tears. He coiled up on the dirty blankets beneath him and stared up at the cobwebs on the ceiling. His body was too heavy to move as he allowed himself to lay there and truly feel emotions for the first time since he was eight.

He softly hummed the melody of *The Dance of the Love Birds* as he laid there, head full of the boy with green eyes.

"Happy birthday," Katsuki whispered to the childhood ghost.

He could see a transparent visual of the boy with green eyes in the nook laying with him. The boy smiled brightly and sweetly called him 'Kacchan.' He imagined his friend tucking him in one last time, giving him that caring kiss on the cheek before exiting the nook with a sad smile.

"Goodbye, Kacchan."

"…Goodbye."

That was the last time Katsuki ever allowed himself to cry.

He boxed up his emotions along with the notion of being a child.

On the train ride back home, Katsuki concluded that the small, year-long interlude of his life was a happy blip. A mistake in the divine plan that was not meant for someone like him.

The years following that were filled with a type of sorrow Katsuki would come to know as his real home. Looking back on that year was both happily blissful and scorchingly painful. The parts that evoked hurt felt like venom in his veins to think about. The bruises. The broken bones. His mother's lying. The guilt of leaving. It all added up until it crushed him under a landslide of self-hate.

However, the blissful parts were nice. Whenever the dreary days weighed too much on his soul, he thought of the boy with green eyes and those nice pieces of his childhood. Those days were bright, joyful and gave him something to peacefully dream about.

But most of all, it was the only proof Katsuki had that someone loved him at one point.

He wished one day he had the opportunity to say it back. His only desperate wish was to let the boy with kind eyes know how thankful he was.

However, that moment never came, and Katsuki never got his wish.

Now, whenever he looks back on that year, it stings in a bittersweet way. To stop the past from hurting, Katsuki locked it up tight. He shoved all the good and bad in a volt in the back

of his mind where it was safe out of reach.

It all nearly felt like a dream, until it became one.



By TrippieM1

Chapter End Notes

Please let me know what you think below! Mainly because I think this was my favorite chapter to write thus far. All thoughts, theories, screams, cries are welcome.

This chapter super satisfying for me because I've been super excited to get into both of their backstories. We're getting a bit more ramp up to where the plot is going and their dynamic. ☺💚🧡 Thanks so much for reading!

Chapter 7: Andante

Chapter Summary

Andante (tempo): In a walking tempo, moderately slow.

Chapter Notes

Hello and welcome back to everyone's favorite hitmen husbands!

First, thank you so much for 1000 kudos on this fic! I'm having a ton of fun with it. I love crime AUs a little too much so this is a delight you all are enjoying it as well! Next up, thank you to my moon and stars, LunaToons on AO3 for betaing and giving feedback like always! She's amazing.

Lastly, let's assume as a group Peter Moore doesn't have bugs/cameras around the hotel area. In my mind, he's a tricky criminal who is super careful. The hotel is a real business and has to pass regulations and random checks. With the high influx of visitors he gets he's not going to risk someone finding private cameras in the room and getting his business shut down. He uses the hotel more so to lure people in like flies to honey so he can then kidnap them off the premises. Such as on Ie Island (where his headquarters is) or in the Tanbaru Forest. This way no alarms/connections are directly brought to him.

Okay! Enjoy the chapter.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 7 - Andante

.

.

.

Katsuki was roused awake by the gentle sun. It touched his face lightly in the bright pink tent, warming his skin as he fluttered his eyes open. The lingering weight of nostalgia weighed down on his memory and left him wading in a mental state of limbo.

The only two things in the forefront of his mind were green eyes and curly, dark hair. He could see the blurry faced boy of his past, and he longed to uncover the rest of the phantom vision that haunted his mind.

Katsuki shifted in the sleeping bag, sitting up with a dazed expression. His eyes were hazily unfocused on the world around him. Truthfully, he didn't even feel like he was in the Yanbaru forest. His mind was partially trapped in his memories, like he was still exiting a portal from another realm. Mentally, he had one foot in Tokyo and the other in Okinawa. The side of him still existing in Tokyo had phantom hands pulling on him, tugging and aching for him to return.

He could perfectly see the ghostly visual of the boy, still surrounded by a thin veil of hazy, memory fog.

Katsuki wished he could take his hand and wipe the fog away, view the boy as a whole and finally say thank you—but he knew he couldn't. The boy was forever gone and would probably forever remain a mystery clouded by fog. Reaching down into the visual part of his memory from that long ago felt like attempting to touch the bottom of a well with just his arm's reach.

With mixed frustration and relief, Katsuki carded his calloused hand through his messy hair. He reflected briefly on that year he had repressed in the back of his mind. It was all almost clear to him now like shining crystals in the light save for the tiny details of the boy's face and name.

He hated to admit it, but Momo was good at her job. It had been years since he thought about that era of his childhood and all it took was one nosy ass therapist on vacation for all the mental blocks to come tumbling down.

Katsuki finally pulled himself out of his daze to look down next to him in the sleep bag.

However, he was surprised to find an empty space where he expected to see Izuku. The fluffy white pillow held an indent where Izuku's head should be. All his clothes and hiking gear were packed up and placed neatly off to the side. It was as if the other hitman had awoken early to prepare to leave and possibly had departed already.

Katsuki frowned slightly at that thought. He was unsure why the unannounced absence made him feel disquieted, but it did.

Where did he go?

Led on by a type of curiosity only fucking Izuku could make him feel, Katsuki grumpily crawled out of the sleeping bag to go find the man. He didn't bother changing out of his sleep clothes as he aggressively zipped open the fuschia colored tent to make his way out into the open world.

The gleaming morning sun greeted him first. Then next was the melody of birds chirping and the sound of running water from the river. It was quiet all around the campsite with the smell of smothered out fire filling the air. According to the sky's orangish tint, the time was only brushing past dawn. Which meant no one else was awake. To confirm that thought, Katsuki could hear Shouto snoring lightly from the tent next to theirs.

Katsuki wandered around, feeling strange for even caring where Izuku was.

Maybe it was officially a force of habit from being attached at the hip for several days now. Or maybe he was still concerned about the fact Moore was attempting to *kidnap* the man. Which, now that Katsuki considered it, made him irritated at Deku. Why the hell would that dumbass go off on his own after what happened on the first night?

Katsuki was already considered an aggressive brute of a husband in some of these people's eyes—he didn't care to get pinned as potential murder suspect if his faux husband went missing. Knowing nosy ass Momo, she would perfectly fucking describe his face to police and, *holy hell*, the issues that would come from that would surely make Aizawa kill him to cover up The Company's identity.

As Katsuki wandered around the quiet summer morning, he eventually found Izuku sitting by the riverside. The freckled man's back was facing him, and he was stationed peacefully in the grass. The soft light of the sun haloed his silhouette delicately as he watched the running water flow past him.

Katsuki stepped on a twig as he approached, and the sound made Izuku turn his head. They made eye contact and Katsuki's heart thudded against his chest hard enough to make him stop in his tracks.

Green eyes.

Big, pretty green eyes and dark curly hair.

A chill raked down his spine. It was as though a ghost was standing directly behind him and whispering inaudible, static filled words into his ear: *"It's ~~Izuku~~."*

"…Izuku?" Katsuki said slowly. The name tasted different on his tongue.

"Ah, good morning, Katsuki," Izuku replied with a soft smile. The rims of his eyes were puffy and red. "You're up earlier than I thought you'd be. How did you sleep?"

He didn't answer right away because his tongue felt knotted. For unclear reasons, Izuku's voice fell on his ears differently. An odd sensation tousled around inside of him and Katsuki's brows pinched together as he surveyed the deep viridian irises in front of him.

It was odd. Izuku had big, green eyes and dark curly hair. The same as his unnamed savior. The resemblance of those two vague features tickled the back of Katsuki's head and gave him pause. However, when the silent tension strung too tight, it was clear. Izuku began nervously plucking at the blades of grass underneath him.

"Is…Is everything okay?" Izuku asked meekly. He shyly turned his face away from Katsuki's intense gaze to glance down at the ground pensively. "I-I didn't mean to wake you up if I did."

"Er—no. You didn't," Katsuki corrected quickly. He realized he was, *once again*, staring a little too hard at Izuku. Why the hell did he do that so much? "I was surprised to find you gone, that's all. Y'know, there's still a creepy human trafficker trying to snatch you up in these woods."

Izuku nodded distantly without saying a word.

Katsuki decided then to brush off the strange, ghostly feeling. He was making shit weird between them again. He did his best to move on from the peculiar sensation that was evoked by his odd dreams and memories. That year of his life seemed to be plaguing him recently and he couldn't afford for it to spill over on this assignment. It was his last, he should stay level headed. Katsuki decided at that moment to deal with the childhood memories later—or maybe never.

Izuku arose from his spot on the river side to approach him with an unreadable emotion dancing in his eyes. He gave Katsuki a kind smile before walking past him.

"Let's head back and finish packing, we'll be going back to the hotel soon," Izuku said with his back turned and shoulders tense.

"Sure thing," Katsuki replied quietly, feeling unusual.

He frowned at the retreating backside of his faux husband, put off by the bizarre exchange.

☽ ☽ ☽

When they returned back to the campground area, Momo and Jirou were up and about. The two girlfriends greeted them with warm hellos. Izuku greeted them too and gradually the chit chat between the four of them woke up the other two couples. All of their Paradise Crew began cleaning up their campsite and packing up their respective tents.

Katsuki was happy that he and Izuku were flowing easier, but he was slightly irked. Irked for a reason he didn't exactly *like* because he was annoyed at the fact Izuku was being quiet around him. Why the hell did he care? He and Izuku weren't exactly chatty, but normally there was some level of sarcastic banter between them. Katsuki realized then he had become accustomed to the back-and-forth tug of war he and Izuku had.

But now, that was missing for the first time in eight years.

Izuku looked damn near exhausted today and gave him *nothing*.

They got dressed without a word. Izuku put on a simple bubble gum pink t-shirt that said 'beach clothes' in cutesy white lettering and light-blue jeans shorts. Katsuki put on his usual black tee, silver chain, and black colored pants.

After getting fully dressed, they took down the small tent and Katsuki expected some level of sarcasm from Izuku. But the little shit didn't make a single goddamn jab at him or respond to any of the sarcasm Katsuki threw his way. It felt *wrong*.

But what was stranger was how Izuku was being oddly gentle with him.

He offered to pack up Katsuki's belongings for him while Katsuki packed up the van. Each one of his pieces of clothing were neatly folded and placed in his backpack with care when Katsuki checked.

It made him curiously peer at Izuku who silently gave him a gentle smile.

They all got back into the van in the same seating fashion as before. This time neither he nor Izuku made a fuss about the seating arrangement. Out of habit, or finally learning how to play pretend husband, Katsuki helped Izuku into his lap and buckled them in without an argument.

The van began to move and slowly Katsuki watched the green forest behind them fade into the background. He turned his head forward and caught sight of Izuku. His faux husband was stiff in his lap like before, but this time the mood was different as the smaller man stayed utterly silent. He appeared entirely uncomfortable for different reasons now as he wrung his wrists.

Izuku leaned forward, awkwardly shifted to place his head on the window. From this view, Katsuki couldn't see his face, but he could see Izuku's head droop. His body periodically jerked as though he was drifting in and out of sleep but struggled to stay under.

Katsuki exhaled through his nose slightly and decided to lean forward to whisper subtly in Izuku's ear.

"Hey, are you okay?" He asked, despite himself. He didn't want to give a shit, but clearly something was off. "You've been quiet. Usually, you're annoying the shit out of me by now."

Izuku perked up, surprised. He twisted slightly to peer at Katsuki behind him with a distracted look on his face.

"Sorry," Izuku said quietly, his eyes skirted downwards. "I…I didn't get any sleep last night. I think I was too on edge and it's finally catching up to me."

Katsuki pursed his lips, looking at the slightly-less-puffy rims of Izuku's eyes. He wasn't quite sure that was the whole truth, but he decided to take it. The van hit another bump, and they both jerked in tandem. At that moment, Katsuki could clearly see the exhaustion on Izuku's face.

"Lean back," Katsuki simply commanded, led on by a pull in his chest. "You're not going to get any rest hunched over like that."

He moved backwards himself to emphasize his point and gestured for Izuku to do the same. Izuku's eyes widened and his face deepened with a red blush. He shook his head rapidly.

"No, it's okay—"

"—C'mon," Katsuki said forcefully with an annoyed inflection. "Lean back. I'll steady you while you nap. Ain't an issue after fucking cuddling damn near nude in your little panties. Nothing can be more embarrassing than that."

He grabbed Izuku's shoulders and slightly pulled to ease him into it. At first, Izuku gave some resistance, grimacing at the prospect. Then when Katsuki tightened his grip on Izuku's tense shoulders, the smaller man steadily gave in and inched backwards.

Katsuki watched how Izuku exhaled in defeat before leaning all the way backwards, and pressed flush against his chest. Izuku shifted slightly to get more comfortable and Katsuki helped him, snuggly fitting the smaller body against him. He wrapped his arms around Izuku's middle and when they hit another bump, it was barely noticeable with the protective hold.

Izuku laxed all the way, and comfortably leaned his head against Katsuki's shoulder. He turned his face inwards to the crook of Katsuki's neck, making his breath tickle Katsuki's skin lightly like feathers. The blond hitman studied the way Izuku hesitantly lifted his hands. He placed them over Katsuki's arms that were holding him in place. The soft fingers squeezed him lightly, as though to make sure he was real.

"Better?" Katsuki asked.

"Better," Izuku agreed with relief. He gave a tiny smile and looked up at Katsuki with that same unreadable expression. "Thank you."

"Don't mention it, dork."

Tired, green eyes looked right into his own and Katsuki's heart skipped a beat.

"You're…here," Izuku muttered distantly, voice laced with sleep. "I'm glad you're here."

Katsuki wasn't exactly sure how to respond. Izuku's fingers began to draw tiny circles on his arm then steadily, Izuku drifted off to sleep.

Katsuki didn't dwell on the small act of affection nor the erratic beating of his own heart. He reasoned they were still attempting to play pretend husbands when he glanced to the front and could see Shouto watching them through the rear-view mirror. Katsuki had forgotten the other six bodies in the van, truthfully. He had been too focused on making sure Izuku was comfortable.

Then a small snore reached his ears and Izuku nuzzled into his neck more.

Scarlet eyes shifted to the window to distract himself from the twisting in his chest as he tightened his hold on Izuku. Katsuki lazily watched all the large trees of the forest shrink in perspective. They grew tinier and tinier as they drove down the mountains, away from the tranquil environment. The wind blew through the leaves, rustling them and it appeared as if they were waving goodbye to them.

A small piece of Katsuki felt inexplicably dejected to see the forest fade. He knew that all the leisure demeanor that came with it would soon diminish as well. A shift in the air settled into him as he realized when they made it down the mountain, his cell phone signal would return.

When that happened, he would have to check back into reality.

Katsuki quietly gazed between the fading forest and the man sleeping soundly in his arms. He studied Izuku's dark, curly hair and thought about his pretty, green eyes.

His heart clutched in an unusual manner.

☽ ☽ ☽

When they finally arrived back at the pastel pink hotel, it was exactly how they left it.

The welcoming palm trees casted shadows over them in the subtropical heat as hordes of vacation goers were checking in and out. Couples flooded the premises hand in hand smiling and giggling at each other. The lovesickness in the air was tangible with invisible hearts floating over the masses and the sticky feeling of adoration clung to everyone.

Katsuki sighed lightly as they all got out of the van. Izuku looked far more refreshed and was slightly chattier as they grabbed their bags. Shouto returned the keys to the front desk as everyone gave hugs and parted ways for the day. When it was only the two of them standing in the center of the marble floored lobby, both hitmen reluctantly took out their cell phones.

Katsuki winced and Izuku grimaced deeply.

60 missed calls and 40 goddamn text messages.

Everything was mostly from Aizawa. A handful were from Sero and there was one from fucking Denki. Katsuki grumpily read the first three recent messages on his phone. It was a mess. A pure, fucking mess. He could practically feel Aizawa's hands around his throat, strangling him nearly to death through his sheer spite across the country.

[Dumbass Denki]: Dude!! you're in maaaajor trouble, where are you????

[Sero Hanta]: I hope getting skinned alive is one of your many weird kinks because Aizawa is going to murder you

[The Old Man]: Bakugou.

Katsuki groaned loudly and scratched behind his head. *Fuck*.

He hesitantly glanced at the man next to him, who was clicking through what seemed like a wide variety of messages as well. With each click, the color from Izuku's face drained more and more until he was visibly pale. Izuku lightly cursed under his breath when he clicked on his email app.

Katsuki supposed they both were in some level of shit.

Izuku cut his eyes towards him and gave a sheepish smile. "I, uh, have to go call my handler A.S.A.P. Should we head upstairs?"

"I have to call my boss too," Katsuki said. He fiddled with his phone unsure if he should even have this convo around Izuku. The weight of the phone in his hand and seeing Aizawa's name graciously reminded him that his boss instructed him to slaughter Izuku on sight. "I…I should probably do it in private, so I think I'm going to find a spot elsewhere. No offense."

"Uh, yeah, you're right," Izuku agreed quickly, looking embarrassed. "Here, let me take your bag upstairs for you."

Katsuki was caught off guard slightly when Izuku moved quickly.

The other hitman grabbed his backpack for him, easily handling it and gave him a sweet smile—*again*. Before Katsuki could say anything, his faux husband was already heading off in the direction of the magenta painted elevators with both of their bags.

Katsuki frowned slightly at the kind gesture and the stiff posture.

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki found himself wandering in the back of the hotel until he stumbled upon a peaceful rose garden.

The rose garden itself was expansive. Roses of all colors were sorted off into sections, making it appear color coded. Red. Purple. Blue. Even orange flowers were planted. To compliment the lush greenery, the large garden was decorated with luxe marble statues and beautiful fountains. Intricately carved chestnut colored wooden benches were stationed all around for people to sit at. But off to the side was something else that caught Katsuki's attention.

It was a garden maze.

The entrance of it was a delicate wooden garden archway that was painted white. It was encased in overgrown green vines and pink flowers.

It beckoned Katsuki to come inside, and he eventually wandered in. It would be the perfect place for privacy, he reasoned. As he walked through, Katsuki took in the tiny details. The pure green hedges of the maze twirled and winded through the lush backyard of the hotel. All the hedges were perfectly trimmed with not a single twig out of place. The tall rows were far above Katsuki's head, making him feel small almost.

He walked down the maze's path that was full of brown gravel and silver stones. At every new turn was a wooden garden archway that had luscious vines entangled all over like at the entrance. Lavender bell flowers hung from the vines of the archways that led Katsuki down this private path. When he felt like he was deep in the maze, he stumbled across a large circular opening. In the center was a white marble fountain with a figure of a weeping woman cradling a large vase. Out of the mouth of the vase came the pouring water.

Katsuki surveyed the area to make sure he was alone before sitting on the edge of the expensive fountain.

He mulled over Izuku and the whole fake marriage charade first.

For a brief moment, Katsuki contemplated telling Aizawa the full details of the mess he was in. Maybe he could get some advice on how to properly go about it? But then he attempted to figure out how to even fucking explain that he was currently teamed up with the same green nuisance he had been complaining about for *eight* years.

He looked down at the wedding band on his ring finger and twisted it while thinking of pretty green eyes. Izuku turned out not to be as terrible as he thought. In fact, even though he was a little shit there was a lot about his presence Katsuki was begrudgingly fond of.

But quickly, he imagined himself explaining what had happened to Aizawa, specifically the part where he showed Izuku the details of the red folder. The *exclusive top secret* red folder that no one else's eyes were ever supposed to see. After that, he could perfectly hear Aizawa curse him out, and then book a flight to come kick his ass.

Yeah, let's not tell him about Izuku, Katsuki thought to himself, wincing. *Keep that shit to yourself and take it to your fucking grave.*

He stopped fiddling with the wedding band and reluctantly dialed Aizawa's number.

Immediately the phone was picked up before the first ring could complete.

"You better have a *really* good reason why you've been unreachable for the last *forty-eight hours*," Aizawa instantly snapped through the phone. Katsuki winced and pulled the phone away from his ear when his supervisor's voice raised loudly. "Why the fuck would you drop a *code 119* and then disappear to Kami knows where, you thick headed *child*?"

"Look, I've been trying to keep a low fucking profile so don't yell at me, old man," Katsuki snapped back. His eyebrow twitched in irritation. "I won some lottery to go camping in the woods for free. I had no signal for the last two days."

"Why the *hell* would you even enter a lottery—"

"—I didn't," Katsuki hissed defensively. "It was randomized. But where the hell were *you*? While you're so busy yelling at me, I called you *right* away and you didn't even answer or return my call that day or the next morning."

There was a long pause on the other end.

"…Sorry about that," Aizawa said as he exhaled roughly. Katsuki knew that exhausted sigh well and could perfectly envision his long-time mentor pinching the bridge of his nose to calm down. "I got busy and was in Czechia trying to behead a snake."

Katsuki glowered at the coded language. "Behead a snake? What the hell does that mean?"

"It means it's above your pay grade," Aizawa said brusquely.

"You're always so fucking shady," Katsuki griped. He hunched forward, deciding to drop it. "So, what should I do? Those cops are in my *Paradise Crew* here. Do we drop the assignment? I think they're attempting to make an arrest."

"We can't drop the assignment," Aizawa said calmly. "While you were busy *camping*, I ran the red flag by the clients, and everyone agrees Moore needs to be put down. None of the stakeholders in the governments believe he deserves a right to a fair trial, and no one wants the police involved to open a possible deeper investigation."

"…Really?"

"Really."

There was another long pause and Katsuki could hear Aizawa light a cigarette on the other end.

"Honestly, between you and I," Aizawa said quietly. His voice was hush and low. "It seems like they want him quietly disposed of so some dirt on themselves doesn't come forward."

"What dirt could a human trafficker have on government officials?" Katsuki whispered back.

"I'm afraid that's what I was abroad attempting to figure out," Aizawa grumbled. "I don't usually like when full circumstances aren't disclosed to us before we send a man on an assignment. But it turns out, whatever dirt is between them is above *both* our pay grades. So, just finish off this assignment and come back so you can retire, alright? Last assignment so no more questions. Remember, we get issued the folders and execute the jobs, nothing more. A mark is a mark. Always remember that."

"Right. A mark is a mark."

That small, simple line was The Company's motto and something Aizawa hammered into him since he was fourteen.

A mark is a mark at the end of the day.

No emotions. No questions. Just do the job and do it well. It reminded Katsuki to stay grounded and get out of this paradise from hell alive and well.

"See if you could possibly probe those two cops for when they're going to do a raid, it might be around their scheduled check out time," Aizawa continued. "We need to be ahead of the curve on them. Under *no* circumstances do you allow them to arrest Peter Moore. You snipe him dead from a distance if they have him in handcuffs, got it?"

"Got it," Katsuki repeated dutifully. "I'll make sure to finish it before any of that occurs, old man."

"Good. I'm counting on you. No more hiccups and please, *fucking please*, no more camping trips."

"Yeah, yeah, I heard you."

"Alright, I have to go. Keep me updated."

"Bye, old man. Remember to take your vitamins."

"Goodbye Bakugou. Remember to keep your head on straight."

The line clicked and Katsuki took a deep breath in to stay centered. He fiddled with his phone in his hand pensively and thought about the assignment.

It was a little obscure the more Katsuki dwelled on it.

Usually when police were involved, Katsuki would be immediately ordered to return to headquarters. However, on the other hand, they weren't usually hired by politicians for red folder assignments. Their red folder assignment clientele were usually gruff, shady crimelords. Politicians were usually green or yellow folders. The hard tone Aizawa used made it clear as day that Moore needed to be six feet under before Katsuki stepped foot off Okinawa.

He felt a headache incoming when he thought about all the stupid ass complications.

Undercover cops. His faux fucking husband he was *supposed* to kill—and now that same husband was officially branded to be kidnapped by the very man they were attempting to murder. There was so much that could go wrong before they successfully staged the murder-suicide they were planning.

Everything about this case was shaping up to be out of the ordinary.

☽ ☽ ☽

When Katsuki made his way back up to their room, he was surprised to find Izuku sitting on the edge of the bed looking at his phone pensively. It was a stark contrast to see the sullen man sitting there on the edge of that large, heart shaped bed. His dark green hair and deep green eyes perfectly juxtaposed the silk scarlet colored bedding as he hung his head.

Katsuki fully stepped in the room and he wasn't immediately given any mind. There was a distant expression swirling inside of Izuku's emerald eyes, as if considering something. The freckled man didn't even bother to look up.

Izuku pursed his lips to the side as he read a message on his phone.

Katsuki slowly shut the door, and the clicking sound finally caught Izuku's attention. Izuku snapped his head up and locked his phone swiftly with a single click of the side button.

"Hey," Izuku said a little too quickly. He gave another gentle smile to Katsuki and tilted his head. "What did your handler say?"

"Well. After chewing my head off, he told me I have to stay and finish off the assignment," Katsuki admitted. He walked over and sat on the edge of the bed next to Izuku. "How about you?"

Izuku fiddled with the phone in his hands as a droplet of silence spilled between them.

"Same," Izuku eventually said tightly. He smiled and tucked his phone in his pants' pockets. "We still need to put distance between us and the cops in the meantime preferably."

"Yeah, that's fine," Katsuki said. He hunched over and looked at Izuku with a serious expression. "I was advised to attempt to find out their check out time. That could possibly lead us to seeing if and when they're going to do a raid. Basically, I can't let them arrest Moore."

Izuku nodded. “Okay. That works.”

Katsuki stood up and stretched with a loud yawn.

He started going over scenarios in his mind on how the hell they were going to press that information out of the two cops—if they even could. Maybe they could try to kill Moore as soon as possible. But then that could get sticky if they found themselves in a hive of fucking police at bad timing. Cops were dumb but not dumb enough not to question two men who showed up dressed in all black with fully loaded guns to a king pin’s headquarters.

After going through a couple scenarios in his mind, Katsuki turned around.

He was a little surprised to find Izuku eying him up and down, clearly not even fucking thinking about their assignment. Green eyes were filled to the brim with curiosity as Izuku’s hands were tightly clasped together. Katsuki raised a brow when the freckled hitman ran his eyes up and down his whole goddamn body.

“Did you get a good enough look?” Katsuki teased sarcastically, wanting to see if Izuku would finally respond to some banter. ”I can turn to the side for you if you need another angle.”

Izuku quickly turned away with a pink flush on his face. “I-I wasn’t looking at you. I was zoning out.”

“Yah-huh. Sure you weren’t.” Katsuki rolled his eyes. “Well, what now?”

“We should wait until dinner when we see Shouto and Inasa again,” Izuku suggested. “We’ll poke around then with some questions. But uh, maybe we can relax in the lounge area? We have to pretend like we didn’t dispose of the bartender in the woods so hiding away only makes us look suspicious right now. But if we go to the bar lounge and look ignorant, it’ll seem like we don’t know anything. Let me buy you a drink or something.”

He silently agreed with the notion of going to the lounge area, but he grinned a little at the naivety of Izuku in the last sentence. With the way big green eyes gazed at him, Katsuki knew Izuku didn’t know the implications of that saying, which made it more humorous.

“Buy me a drink, huh?” Katsuki repeated with a hint of amusement. “Why does that sound like you’re flirting with me, nerd?”

Then, on cue, Izuku spluttered and blushed like he usually did.

“I-I’m not!” Izuku denied swiftly, clearly scandalized. His eyes went wide with embarrassment as he waved his hands. “I-I was only being nice.”

“You sure? First you gawk at me and now you want to buy me a drink. Doesn’t sound *just* nice to me.”

“Nevermind, Katsuki,” Izuku mumbled, his face fully red. “Why do you always make such crude comments?”

Katsuki grinned at the stupid little pout he was given when the air around them went back to normal.

“I’m not the one offering to buy *you* a drink, Deku. Next time just ask me on a date.”

“Just forget it. Disregard that I ever offered.”

Katsuki barked out a sharp laugh when Izuku stood up and hurried out of the door of their room, face in flames.

☽ ☽ ☽

They made their way down to the lobby bar side by side with their usual banter restored. It made Katsuki a lot happier, even though he sure as hell wouldn’t admit it out loud. But getting a response out of Izuku was something Katsuki needed more than he thought.

As they were walking, they fell into a small lull. In his mind Katsuki was diligently plotting on how to possibly pressure the two cops into giving them details. Then his thoughts were abruptly halted when a small hand grabbed his unexpectedly. It took Katsuki slightly off guard, especially since they weren’t around people. What was the point in holding hands right *now*?

He turned to Izuku, waiting for some sort of explanation. But in place of words, he saw a deep red blush. The demeanor made Katsuki quiet as well, but he still let Izuku intertwine their fingers together.

For the first time, it didn’t feel weird.

In fact, it was comforting. And in an odd way, familiar.

“I think this is the first time you didn’t put up a fight with me over holding hands,” Izuku said gently. He gazed up at Katsuki in a proud manner.

“Don’t tempt me,” Katsuki mumbled without any real bite.

He smirked down at Izuku who smiled up at him fondly.

Katsuki was about to make another sarcastic jab but stopped when he felt a tender caress on his hand. Scarlet eyes snapped downwards, unsure if he felt that right. But there it was. Izuku’s thumb was lightly caressing him in a private, affectionate manner. A gesture that was solely saved for lovers—and currently they weren’t in front of anyone they had to convince that they were devoted husbands.

Katsuki raised a single brow.

He cut his eye towards Izuku who quickly turned away from him like he was caught. The caressing immediately stopped. Izuku awkwardly chuckled and scratched behind his head.

“Sorry, I-I didn’t realize what I was doing for a moment,” Izuku quickly covered up. “I must still be sleep deprived.”

Katsuki was a bit confused and speechless.

...What the hell?

He briefly considered maybe Izuku was pitying him to an extent. He *had* accidentally let their whole fucking paradise crew know about his mommy issues last night. *Dead* mommy issues on top of it. Not everyday you find out the guy you hated for eight years had an strung out, grambling addicted mother.

Maybe Izuku was being bizarrely kinder to him because of it—which soured Katsuki slightly.

He hated, no, *despised* people who pitied him. It's why he didn't fucking talk about his past trials and tribulations to the extras in his life. If he ever mentioned his situation, their eyes would soften, voices coo like he was a toddler and they would start treating him like he was a single traumatic event away from a full breakdown. Deep down, Katsuki didn't want Izuku to treat him like that.

But—maybe the kindness was because of another reason.

Katsuki sucked at his teeth.

He reflected on all the people who always wanted to get into his pants. He refused to take partners who pitied him. It made him sick to his stomach to even think about a pity fuck. That mere concept was the reason why he only fucked people who expressed pure, untainted sexual attraction to him. Anyone who wanted to see what he was like in bed was *always* ultra-nice before dropping to their knees in front of him.

He thought about Izuku's erection in the car ride and the cave cuddling.

He unwillingly pondered how Izuku would look down on his knees.

They arrived in the packed lounge, and like usual people were all around. The blond attempted to ignore the tender caressing on his hand that had picked up again. He wanted to chalk the behavior up to Izuku's sleep deprivation—but the sensation of that gentle touch felt like it was attempting to translate some unknown message to him.

Katsuki tried to distract himself from the fuzziness that the caressessing evoked by looking around the lounge. Friend groups were joking around tables, others were playing darts and pool and several others were stationed at the bar.

The two of them casually made their way over to the bar area and immediately they picked up on the replacement for the bartender.

The man they had disposed of in the woods was replaced with a taller, buffer man who looked a hell of a lot meaner. He had a buzz cut and in the shotty lighting could Katsuki make out his hair to be dark purple. The new bartender's eyes were a sharp teal that dug into both him and Izuku in a scrutinizing manner. He had a nasty scar over his eye and an aura that screamed even to Katsuki that he'd be a future problem.

Whoever this replacement was, he sure as hell wasn't a bartender.

The pair ordered drinks in the crowded lounge, making sure not to give away anything. It felt like playing mental chess as they fake flirted in front of the bartender. They had to be two to three steps ahead of Moore, elegantly playing a waltz of loving husbands.

Izuku was leaning into him, still holding his hand. He had an adorable smile that made even the anti-romantic hitman smirk back at him. Izuku squeezed his hand and the private, tender gesture continued.

Warmth settled into Katsuki's chest as Izuku's thumb continued to softly traced circles—and it was beginning to confuse the hell out of Katsuki.

He couldn't distinguish what was real and what was for show anymore.

To make matters worse, despite Izuku's words upstairs, he still bought his drink for him.

The freckled hitman heavily insisted and offered to buy him all the drinks he wanted. He called over the bartender and placed an order for two piña coladas after Katsuki said the fruity drink was his favorite. They both watched the menacing bartender awkwardly fumble with making their cocktails—clearly not his fucking forte. The gruff man had to remake them *twice* before the two glasses were slid over to them with a rehearsed smile.

Then after studying both of them closely, the frightening man walked off the other side of the long bar, tending to other couples after a while.

They drank down their beverage with light conversation. The entire time Izuku was gazing at him like he was fascinated with him. Big ass green eyes stared at his face, and even darted to his arms the second Katsuki rolled up his sleeves. At first, he thought Izuku was simply putting on the doting husband act. But when the bartender was clearly not even fucking looking at them anymore, Izuku *still* didn't stop.

The hand intertwined with his own didn't leave. And the soft gentle on and off caressing kept on. Izuku gazed at him like he was a long lost friend and then the freckled hitman started asking him all about his *life*.

"Did you always live in Tokyo, or did you move elsewhere after you were a kid?" Izuku asked with a curious glitter in his eyes.

"Besides classical music, what other musicians do you listen to?" He pressed when Katsuki mentioned knowing the song playing from the speakers above their head.

"You're really funny, do you have a lot of friends?" Izuku chuckled with a shy blush when Katsuki made an offhand comment about a man's toupee.

It made Katsuki struggle between what was real and what was not again. Izuku seemed genuinely interested in getting to know him—far more than before the dumb camping trip.

Something had changed. He didn't know *what*, but something did.

When Izuku brushed a stray lock of hair out of face, Katsuki pursed his lips.

The freckled hitman was being nice to him. A little too nice for Katsuki to write it off as his faux polite demeanor. What the hell was going on?

When both of their drinks were empty, Katsuki took a bite of the sweet pineapple on the rim of his drink's empty glass. He enjoyed the feeling of the refreshing fruity taste across his taste buds and hummed happily. Before he could even place down the discarded rim of the pineapple, Izuku quickly plucked the pineapple from his own glass and placed it onto Katsuki's.

Katsuki's eyes blinked slowly, caught off guard again.

"You don't want it?" Katsuki asked carefully.

"You can have it," Izuku insisted. "You seem to like pineapple."

Katsuki squinted his eyes. Izuku kindheartedly smiled at him once more.

He licked the pineapple while looking at Izuku. Then on the flip of a coin, Izuku's eyes subtly darted down to look directly at his mouth. It was the same discreet gaze the nerd had during the baking class, and it was so fucking obvious Izuku was checking him out—*again*. The damn dork probably didn't even realize it as his big ass eyes were trained on Katsuki's mouth.

Katsuki raised a single brow before testing a theory.

He gave the slice of pineapple a long, very gracious suck and let the juices dribble down the sides of his mouth.

Izuku's face blushed deeply and he modestly squeezed his thighs together.

Oh. There it is.

Katsuki looked at Izuku's thighs and a warmth trickled in. He tried to guess what color panties the nerd was wearing. Pink? Red? *Green*? When his own body tingled slightly, Katsuki continued to suck into the pineapple with sloppy wet sounds, enjoying the way Izuku failed at muffling how his breath hitched. Katsuki swallowed the sweet chunk of fruit and Izuku's dilated eyes so clearly followed the bob of his Adam's apple.

Katsuki pensively gauged the freckled man up and down.

"Oi. You're staring at me," Katsuki said with a twinge of satisfaction. He leaned his weight against the bar counter and tilted his head at the man who was undoubtedly in a trance. "You keep ogling me like a piece of fucking meat."

Green eyes blinked rapidly and Izuku shook his head in defense. "Oh—I was just looking at h-how big you got."

“How big I *got*?” Katsuki scrunched his nose at the strange comment. “The hell does that mean?”

“S-Since Vienna!” Izuku immediately snapped out of his daze. He was far more alert now as he spluttered in embarrassment. “You—You’ve g-gotten big! Y’know, since we f-first…met.”

“So, you’re admitting to checking me out without shame now?” Katsuki raised an eyebrow.

“What? *No*! I have never checked you out before—”

“—You little fucking liar. I know you’ve been eyeballing me. I’ve caught you *several* times.”

“Well, for someone who keeps calling me an eyesore, I’ve caught you too,” Izuku huffed like a child snapping back at an accusation.

“*And*? I’m not going to deny it right now.” Katsuki leaned in with a slight smirk when Izuku froze.

He moved in close enough to feel Izuku’s breathing change and see how the other man stiffened in the barstool but didn’t lean backwards. Green eyes darted between Katsuki’s wet mouth and his burning red eyes as the blond moved in closer to him. Katsuki flexed a brow before giving a smirk. For an unknown reason, the idea that Izuku was into him made his ego swell high.

“You’ve been awfully nice to me all day, and that usually means one of two things,” Katsuki whispered, dropping his voice low. “You either pity me after what I spilled during the camping trip, or you want to fuck me. Which is it?”

Izuku was rendered speechless like he was stuck between the two choices.

He hung his mouth open, searching for the words.

For the first time, Katsuki looked at the other hitman’s lips in a different light. Scarlet eyes darkened as he studied how goddamn plump and pink they were.

That half of his brain that usually reminded him how acting on his attraction to Izuku was a terrible idea was suddenly utterly quiet. All the bullets, punches, and stab wounds exchanged now all appeared to be maybe violent foreplay in his mind as he considered the other hitman in a more erotic light.

“Well? Which is it?” Katsuki pried in a low whisper, unsure why he was burning to know.

The freckled hitman furrowed his brows, seemingly conflicted.

Before Izuku could answer, suddenly two figures approached them.

One man was dressed in an all-white suit and the other in a sleek black one. Moore and his assistant were standing side by side with their shining golden dove pins on their collars like shining symbols of hospitality.

Of fucking *course*.

The tension in the air was immediately broken down with the presence of the two people they were plotting to kill. Katsuki lazily wiped the pineapple juices off his mouth with the back of his hand and Izuku rubbed his blushing nape, clearly flustered.

Katsuki discreetly cut his eyes at the bartender across the way. The gruff man was putting his cell phone away in his pink apron.

“Welcome back to my favorite couple!” Moore said cheerily.

The hotel owner flashed his usual enchanting smile, but it was off kilter now. It wasn’t all the way convincing. There was a crack in his well-formed mask, making the shining pearly white smile appear dimmer.

“Yes. Incredibly nice to see you two together,” Moore assistant, Minoru Koizumi, said without any inflection. “We hope you had a lovely trip.”

The skinny dark-haired man gave a taut closed lipped smile at both of them. The smile stopped right below the dark circles on his sunken face and the creases of his eyes didn’t upturn all the way. It was so obvious to Katsuki both of these men were extremely displeased to see him breathing and Izuku not shipped off to who knows where.

“Yes, it was so fun!” Izuku laughed. He gave a polite grin and took a sip of his drink. “I’ve never been camping, so thank you for that experience.”

“It’s no problem at all,” Moore said. He smoothed out the wrinkles on his suit with a tight smile. “Would you two want to talk about it more in my private lounge around the corner? I’m always looking for ways to improve the paradise experience!”

Fucking slime ball.

The goosebumps on Katsuki’s arm ignited and a chill crawled up the hills of his spine. All three sets of eyes were carefully looking at him and Izuku. The bartender cleaned a glass a little too aggressively. Moore didn’t stop smiling and a tiny twitch in his brow was notable. Then finally Koizumi squinted his eyes ever so slightly.

The hold Izuku had on his hand tightened.

“Yeah, we wouldn’t mind,” Katsuki said wisely. “We have to be back for dinner though. Our crew doesn’t like to eat without us.”

He could see both Moore and his assistant stiffen at that. It was carefully worded enough to let the two traffickers think they had the people in their Paradise Crew waiting for them.

“Yes, we all got super close on the trip!” Izuku emphasized with a charismatic chuckle. “Thank you for that, again. We’re like all best friends now.”

“Of course, glad to hear it,” Koizumi said, clearly forced. “How about we chat about your trip over a game of billiards. Do you two play by any chance?”

“I’m decent at it.” Katsuki shrugged.

“I’ve played a couple of times,” Izuku said.

“Perfect! Let’s go play a game,” Moore said with a perk in his voice. “Come this way!”

They two men gestured for him and Izuku to follow them as their golden dove pins caught the light.

When both Moore and Koizumi’s backs were turned, Izuku and Katsuki exchanged serious expressions.

☽ ☽ ☽

They were led to a room that was stationed discreetly in the lounge area.

It was hidden away in a tiny nook and behind a mahogany door with a golden nob. Moore opened it with a bright, welcoming smile and sitting inside was a room that contrasted against the whole setting of the hotel. Nowhere in sight was a lick of pink, and instead all around them was luxe, polished dark colored wood and deep wine colored walls.

Black leather couches were stationed next to tall wooden bookshelves that were full of novels with deep colors like moss, crimson, and navy blue. In the center of the room was a green billiards table and off to the side were exactly four cue stickers. Sitting on all four walls were opulent oil paintings with dark golden frames, countless shiny awards, and pictures of Moore with what looked like politicians.

One of them Katsuki recognized was the governor of Tokyo. The two were shaking hands and cutting a big red ribbon on a fancy, tall building.

“Make yourself comfortable,” Koizumi said.

Katsuki watched how Koizume snapped his lanky fingers to the private bar stationed off to the side.

A man with an eyepatch was dressed in a charcoal vest, long white sleeved shirt and velvet obsidian bowtie was standing there, still as a statue. Katsuki was weary how he hadn’t even noticed the man, his breathing practically undetectable. The man began pouring them drinks out of a dark bottle of whiskey without a single smile. The distant sound of the radio was off to the side, reaching Katsuki’s ear a tad.

Izuku wandered around the lounge a bit, admiring all the items perched on the wall. He strolled like he was in an art museum, drinking in all the pictures on the maroon walls before he froze in place. Katsuki noted how he stopped in front of the picture of Moore and the governor of Tokyo in front of that shiny big building.

Izuku cut his eyes towards Moore with a stone cold stare that only Katsuki noticed.

“Tell me all about the camping trip! Start to finish,” Moore asked. He walked up to the bar and took one of the glasses and started to sip on the dark liquid. “I want to hear *every* detail

of how much fun you two had."

Including how we murdered one of your men, Katsuki tacked on in his mind.

Katsuki made a move to grab a cue stick, but Izuku walked over and did it for him. The freckled man chalked up Katsuki's cue stick without a word and then turned to Moore with what Katsuki learned to be his fake grin.

"Oh, you know, we did the whole typical camping thing," Izuku said easily. He moved to chalking up his own cue stick and walked around the pool table to the other side, across from where Katsuki was positioned. "Some kayaking, some s'more making, and we even found this awesome lake with the other people in our crew! And all of that stuff."

"No hiking?" Koizumi said curiously, grabbing a cue stick. He stumbled his heavily decorated ring hand on the wooden surface. "Most people always like to do some hiking."

"Oh, we did a little bit of it with our crew," Izuku explained, waving his hand. "It's a gorgeous forest, seems like a given."

Moore hummed and raked his eyes up and down Izuku's figure slowly.

The hotel owner wordlessly set up eight colorful cue balls in the triangle formation without taking his eyes off the freckled man. He gestured for Izuku to make the first move and Izuku fluidly broke the formation with the first strike.

The loud knocking sound mimicked the tight tension in the room. All four men struggled not to watch each other and focus on the game. The colorful cue balls rolled over the green surface of the pool table and Katsuki eyed how one solid colored ball went into a pocket.

"What time of day or night did you all hike?" Moore asked as he made the next move, missing making a score. The hotel owner pursed his lips displeased before covering it up with a sun bright grin.

"Does it matter what time it was?" Katsuki rebutted.

"I only care to know for my own personal research!" Moore insisted innocently. He leaned his weight onto the cue stick with a friendly grin and gave a hearty laugh. "I want to see what Paradise goers enjoy the most! This always helps me improve upon the experience."

"We did all our hikes when the sun was out if that helps," Katsuki lied easily. "That forest is really big so it's dangerous to hike at night. Plus, Hiroji is afraid of the dark. We make sure we're snuggling in bed before sundown."

Izuku choked on his drink and stared at Katsuki with wide eyes.

Katsuki grinned slightly and shot a wink to Izuku who flushed at the sudden gesture.

"Taro. That's supposed to be *private*," Izuku murmured, playing along. His face pinkened and Katsuki admittedly was starting to enjoy seeing Izuku flustered.

“Sorry, darling,” Katsuki said with a deep chuckle. “You know I find it a little adorable. You have the cutest little phobias.”

He bent over the table to position himself for a shot while making eye contact with Izuku. With a handsome smirk, Katsuki effortlessly knocked three solid-colored cue balls down two pockets without looking. He gave a cocksure grin when Izuku seemed genuinely impressed and tilted his head at him.

Koizumi made the next move, strolling past Katsuki and clearly sizing him up along the way.

The man sauntered a bit too close to him to be seen as friendly and it came across as a mode of intimidation. Katsuki cut his eye at Koizumi, who met his intense stare with his void like eyes. The elder man pushed his hand through his deep black hair, running some of his fingers along the wiry grey strands that were showing in the front before he took a sharp, precise shot at a cue ball and knocked it into the pocket.

“You have good aim,” Katsuki complimented with a fake smirk.

“Same for you,” Koizumi replied as though he was suspicious. “Extremely good aim.”

Katsuki didn’t take the bait and played it off casually.

They continued on with the game with the four of them shuffling around. Koizumi and Katsuki made score after score while Izuku and Moore made some, but not a ton. Katsuki couldn’t tell if this was another faux act, but Izuku complimented and touched him a lot, saying how *great* he was with his *stick*. The freckled hitman fixed the collar on his shirt for him mid-way through the game, hand smoothing out any wrinkles.

When the game winded down, all the questions were easily deflected and answered.

What part of the woods were they in? Hell if they knew.

Did they spend any time away from the group? Nope.

Were there any issues with hiking or did someone in their group wander off? Nope, everyone was as snug as peas in a pod.

After all the intrusive questions and he and Izuku faux flirting, Moore’s friendly façade was slipping. He had an unnaturally tight grip on his cue stick, and Katsuki assumed this was his first time ever being checkmated. The way he was looking at Izuku was concerning Katsuki a bit.

To the untrained average citizen, Moore merely seemed like he was admiring Izuku’s delicate features—especially his eyes. But to Katsuki who had seen the cruel, malicious intentions in the world, he knew Moore was pissed. The look wasn’t one of admiration, it was closer to a low simmer of rage. Like a child who was just told ‘no’ after their parents didn’t purchase the valuable toy they wanted.

To confirm Katsuki’s suspicions, Koizumi was subtly irritated as well. The elder man was picking at his nails while discreetly side eyeing Katsuki.

After he and Izuku slipped through all the subtle intrusive questions without a flaw, both traffickers seemed to be assuming they were just a normal married couple.

There was an expression of doubt traced into Koizumi's and Moore's slightly wrinkled features. Katsuki saw them exchange weary glances that translated to 'maybe that stupid almost-kidnapper really did simply fall off the cliff.' A clear look of defeat was creeping slowly in on Moore's face as they continued playing.

Katsuki had to admit he and Izuku made a damn good team when they were one cue ball away from winning the game.

"You're doing great, darling," Katsuki complimented with a knowing smirk. He easily slung his arm around Izuku's waist in an affectionate manner. "You always pick up on things so fast, I love it."

"Ah, thank you," Izuku said with a mild blush and leaned into him.

"Did you happen to see anything weird by any chance? Or hear anything?" Moore asked in a last-ditch effort.

Katsuki then moved to knock the last cue ball in the hole without removing his arm around Izuku's waist. The ball rolled into the pocket, signaling that they won the game.

"No, why?" Izuku replied with feigned innocence.

"There's been a couple of…hibagon sightings."

"A little fucking strange, but no," Katsuki answered with a shrug. "We didn't see any sasquatches. Only some nice sights of the forest."

"Well," Moore sighed, clearly out of any more questions. He gave them a calm gaze, seemingly not mistrustful of them anymore. "Thank you so much for answering all those questions! Ha. You two are really such a delight. Hiroji, you remind me of my wife so much with how much of a ray of light you are."

Moore's tone indicated that he seemed unsuspecting; however, Koizumi was another story. The dark-haired man was sizing up Izuku and watching them both a little too closely. His dark eyes narrowed distastefully when Izuku placed his hand over Katsuki's.

"Thank you, Mr. Sekai," Izuku replied. He intertwined their fingers, and the subtle clink of their wedding rings could be felt. "I'm sure your wife is a lovely person as well."

Katsuki didn't miss the way Koizumi rolled his eyes and scoffed the second Izuku said 'wife.' The lanky man then wrapped his arm around Moore's shoulders and gave a fake smile, not even bothering to hide his irritation.

"Well, this has been such a pleasure, but my *partner* and I have to be going now," Koizumi quipped and put a little too much emphasis on the word 'partner.' Katsuki's interest piqued a bit. "We have a couple of business engagements to wrap up before the end of the day. Don't we, Henry?"

“O-Oh, yes!” Moore chuckled. He fixed the crooked golden dove pin on his suit. “Please help yourself to the lounge if you would like! Otherwise enjoy the rest of your stay!”

Katsuki and Izuku both waved goodbye to the illicit business partners. The pair left out, signaling for the gruff looking bartender with an eyepatch to follow them.

The tall brute of a man lagged behind the pair like a lap dog, and it made Katsuki nearly scowl. He knew Moore and Koizumi wouldn’t be dumb enough not to travel without extra muscle considering they were in their late fifties but seeing the two new bartenders only meant when the time came, they would have to kill a lot more people than originally planned.

The heavy wooden door clicked shut and both hitmen exhaled loudly.

“Do you think they suspect anything?” Izuku asked. He sat on the end pool table, swinging his legs slightly.

“Nope,” Katsuki said and ran his hands through his hair. “They looked a little defeated and at their wits end. Especially since they’re fucking used *sasquatches* as an excuse to pry about the trip.”

“Yeah, they’re really odd,” Izuku said in a mumble.

“Really odd and really fucking.”

Izuku’s eyes bulged wide. “*What*?”

Katsuki shook his head and downed the rest of his drink, enjoying the burn down his throat.

“You didn’t see the way the creepy crow man rolled his eyes when *the wife* was mentioned?” Katsuki said quietly. “Then on top of it, he was possessively touchy with him at the end. They’re not only business partners, they’re *fucking*. Which—is a fantastic thing for us.”

“Fantastic in what way?”

“What better stage for a murder-suicide than an affair gone wrong? Nothing kills more than love.”

Izuku nodded slowly and caught on. “True. You’re right.”

Katsuki tilted his head at Izuku, who was staring down at the picture of Moore and the governor on the wall now. Green eyes were calculating and there was a small frown on Izuku’s lips as he studied the picture. Katsuki looked at the picture as well, unsure why Izuku was surveying it so hard. Katsuki cleared his throat and decided to change the subject when the silence between them stretched a bit too long.

“You suck at playing pool by the way,” Katsuki teased with a grin. “You’re lucky you had me to carry you the whole time.”

“Ah, I’ve never played,” Izuku laughed distantly with a shrug. He turned his attention to Katsuki and gave him a smile. “This was my first time. But you’re really good, though.”

“Duh. I’m fucking incredible at it,” Katsuki said arrogantly. “I learned when I was a teenager from my supervisor. He wanted someone to play billiards with, so he made me learn when he wasn’t teaching me how to break a man’s neck.”

“That sounds nice,” Izuku said with a soft smile. He tilted his head at Katsuki, and an expression of adoration grew inside of his big green eyes. “Y’know, you’re really amazing at a lot of things it seems like.”

“Yeah, I have a lot of hidden talents,” Katsuki said carefully. “If you’re lucky you might find out more.”

The pink blush on Izuku’s delicate features didn’t go unnoticed by Katsuki. His morbid curiosity burned to know the answer to *why* Izuku was being so damn nice to him.

Was it because of his newly revealed mommy issues or the fact maybe—just maybe—Izuku was slightly into him more than he led on? Maybe that really *was* the reason Izuku didn’t take the kill when he had the chance back in Spain. The other hitman did always emphasize that he had never tried to kill him. Was his guess about a little crush a lot more real than he thought?

He looked at Izuku’s plump ass a little differently.

Katsuki then decided he was going to finish testing his theory.

“Want me to teach you?” Katsuki offered with a sly grin. “Think of it as repayment for helping me get it together for this assignment. We wouldn’t have passed their stupid little lie detector test if you hadn’t showed me how to properly be a doting husband.”

“Sure,” Izuku agreed naively. “I would appreciate that.”

Katsuki motioned with his head for Izuku to come to the other side of the pool table with him as he chalked up his cue stick and reorganized the cue balls.

“First thing, you’re holding the cue stick wrong,” Katsuki said simply. He emphasized his point by holding up his hand. “You’re supposed to make a loop with your pointer finger to steady the cue stick as you shoot.”

He looped his pointer finger over onto his middle and Izuku mirrored him. The green-eyed man curiously tilted his head to see if he did it correctly. Katsuki clicked his tongue and shook his head.

“No, like *this*,” Katsuki pushed.

He stepped forward into Izuku’s space, noting how Izuku’s blush returned due to the proximity. Katsuki carefully reached forward to grab Izuku’s hand with a gentle touch, brushing their palms together. He used his fingers to position Izuku’s fingers into the standard

formation forming the loophole. Green eyes flickered between Katsuki's face and their entangled hands.

"Now that you got the loop formed, you can use it to position the cue stick better," Katsuki explained, purposefully dropping the octave of his voice. "But you have to make sure your body formation is good too."

"Body form?" Izuku asked slowly, eyeing Katsuki carefully.

"Mhm," Katsuki leisurely hummed. He leaned deliberately into Izuku's space, eyes flickering down to the full pink lips that were mere inches away. His senses tingled with the smell of cinnamon and mint. "Body positioning is incredibly important if you want to hit the right angle."

Izuku's gaze grew more intense and Katsuki could see his grip on the cue stick tighten.

Led on by the sudden heat, Katsuki sauntered slowly behind Izuku, regarding his backside up and down. He waited for Izuku to move, say something, but the freckled man remained still like prey willing to be preyed upon. Scarlet eyes raked over the tempting hills and curves of Izuku's body.

Izuku's features looked a lot more appealing under the yellow tinted fluorescent lights. His shiny, silky curls were nearly begging to be fisted and his skin was perfectly soft. Katsuki didn't take his eyes off Izuku's blushing nape as he carefully positioned his hands on Izuku's body.

The freckled man stiffened slightly when Katsuki placed one hand on his hip and the other on the middle of his back. Katsuki leaned forward and pressed his ear directly against the shell of Izuku's ear.

"You have to make sure you're bent over properly," Katsuki instructed.

He pushed on Izuku's back and slowly leaned him downwards. He waited for some level of resistance, but he got none. The corners of Katsuki's mouth twitched upwards as Izuku let himself be suggestively positioned over the pool table. Katsuki dug his fingers into Izuku's hip and curled him ever so slightly to bow his spine.

"And properly arched. Bad arching isn't going to get the results you want."

"Like this?" Izuku said ignorantly. He arched his spine in a position to get a good angle for playing the game, but from his view above, Katsuki was drinking in how eroctic Izuku looked.

"Yeah. Fucking perfect." Katsuki chuckled a bit before pressing his pelvis into Izuku's backside.

There was an audible muffled gasp from Izuku at the sudden contact. The surprised man snapped his head to look up at Katsuki and his freckles were painted dark red. Katsuki played it casually, as though he was merely helping Izuku get the perfect pose for playing billiards.

He leaned over the smaller man until his chest touched Izuku's back. The jingle of his silver chain echoed in the room as he loomed over the smaller man who was looking at him with nearly dilated green eyes.

"Make the loop," Katsuki commanded solidly while maintaining the heated eye contact.

Izuku did as he was told without a word.

He hesitantly looked back towards the cue balls waiting for them. Izuku swallowed and pushed back slightly against Katsuki's solid figure to get a better position, but Katsuki didn't give any leeway. The friction where they were pressed together coiled further as Izuku made the loop with his fingers.

Katsuki placed one hand over the cue stick in Izuku's hand, right above where the warm, smaller hand was. He then moved to wrap his other hand around Izuku's hand that was forming a loop, pinning his wrist down to the table. Izuku held his breath as Katsuki guided the tip of the long wooden cue stick through the tiny loop of Izuku's fingers.

He slowly pushed the stick through the loop with a subtle rock of their bodies. Both red and green eyes watched as Katsuki guided the cue stick in and out and how he did it once more. Izuku swallowed heavily when Katsuki pushed it further than necessary, stretching his fingers around the girthier part of the shaft.

Katsuki hummed as though he was thinking, tilted his head and pressed his slight hard on into Izuku's plush backside more. He trapped the smaller man between him and the hard table's surface when he could feel Izuku's legs slightly shake.

"I-Is this good?" Izuku asked inquisitively.

Izuku squirmed slightly at the tension and there was a mild tremor that raked across his body at the feeling of Katsuki's hard-on pressing into him.

"Tighter," Katsuki whispered into Izuku's ear.

"T-Tighter?"

"Make your hole tighter." The deep rumble in his voice vibrated down both of their flushed together bodies. "It has to be a snug fit."

Izuku faltered slightly before doing as he was told. He only made the loop slightly smaller.

Katsuki 'tsk'd. "You gotta make your little hole tighter than that for me, Izuku."

Izuku then made the loop of his finger smaller until it was a perfect fit around the tip of the cue stick. The freckled man craned his neck until he could make eye contact with Katsuki again. Red and green eyes burned into each other, electricity charging into the air. Katsuki tightened his grip on Izuku's wrist.

"L-Like this?" Izuku whispered. His warm breath tickled Katsuki's lips.

“Yeah, there we go. Just like that,” Katsuki said with a smug look. “Now take the hit.”

Izuku struggled to tear his eyes away from Katsuki while Katsuki relished in the feeling of Izuku slightly trembling against him.

Izuku pushed the cue stick forward through the hole at the same moment Katsuki experimentally pushed into him subtly.

Izuku’s breath hitched in surprise at the motion, but he knocked the eight cue balls with enough force that Katsuki felt the rock in both their bodies. The plush backside slotted against him fucking *perfectly* and Katsuki’s lips twitched into a full smirk. Izuku flawlessly broke the formations of the cue balls, and they scattered all around. Some fell into various pockets on the table while others danced across the green surface aimlessly.

Both hitmen watched them roll around, however Katsuki knew neither of them gave a shit about the game right now.

He could hear Izuku’s breath move into uneven intakes and exhales. Izuku’s shaky hand dropped the cue stick on the table, but Katsuki didn’t remove his hands. He grasped onto both of Izuku’s wrists and pinned them down on the table as his erratic heart started to pick up.

Neither man moved.

Katsuki lowered his head close to the crook of the freckled neck. He hovered enough that if he moved an inch lower, he could place the perfect hickey on the tanned skin. The blush on Izuku’s skin was burning through to the surface and it was tempting as all hell to mark him. Katsuki could feel Izuku tremble against him more, attempting to form words but failing. In place of coherent thought, Katsuki heard the most breathless fucking whine slip past Izuku’s lips.

Then Izuku did something that flipped the situation on its head: he coyly pushed back into Katsuki’s cock and two twin groans spilled into the air.

“*Fuck*,” Katsuki drawled out.

Eagerly, Katsuki ground back on the tight ass that rocked into him. Shots of hot rapture crept up his legs and spilled into his core as they somehow found themselves in a steady, subtle rutting motion against the pool table. Izuku was exhaling through his nose as he tried to move his hands, but Katsuki kept him pinned in place as they moved slowly with steady rolls of their hips.

He leaned into Izuku, making his grinding motion clearer. He lowered his head into the freckled neck and out of instinct, Izuku tilted his head to the side for him. Katsuki brushed his lips over the pulse of Izuku’s jugular before stopping.

“You didn’t answer my question earlier,” Katsuki murmured. “Which is it, *Izuku*? Fuck me or pity me?”

Katsuki rolled his hips harshly and Izuku shuddered.

"*Shit*. Kacc—K-Katsuki, wait—"

Suddenly, a loud, blaring ringtone buzzed into the air.

The sound of the upbeat jingle ripped through the tension and swiftly Izuku shot upright at the sound. He broke out of Katsuki's hold, ungracefully forcing them both upright as he dug into his pockets for his cell phone. Izuku snatched out his smart phone and there was a visible grimace on his face. Katsuki's red eyes glanced down, wondering who was calling and it only confused him when he caught sight of the number '117' in place of a name.

"…I-I have to take this," Izuku whispered distantly, face still flush. "I'll be right back."

The freckled hitman didn't meet Katsuki's gaze as he walked away without another word. The rose-tinted blush sprinkled onto his tanned skin nearly looked permanent. It satisfied Katsuki greatly to witness as he surveyed the way one of Izuku's hands bashfully hid his hard-on in his pants. His hair was ruffled, and he seemed nearly ravished.

The corners of Katsuki's lips twitched upwards into a grin.

Right before Izuku closed the door to the private lounge, their eyes met.

Unspoken words dangled in the air between them, waiting for either man to grasp them.

Katsuki anticipated for something to be said but was met with an unmistakable glance of *longing* from Izuku. Green eyes flickered up and down his body, soaking him in. Then Izuku blushed deeply and shyly glanced away before shuffling off.

The heavy door clicked shut, and Katsuki leaned against the pool table. He crossed his arms, reflected on what had occurred and a confident grin spread across his face.

He felt like he got his answer: Izuku didn't pity him. He *definitely* wanted to fuck him.

If his mind wasn't clouded by lust right now, Katsuki would've understood that him and Izuku having sex was an entirely debauched concept. However, the rational side of Katsuki's thoughts were fully drowned out by the pure, hungry carnal side of his soul. He adjusted the heavy hard on in his pants while mulling over Izuku's own erection. He bit his lip thinking about Izuku's perfect ass and how he always *did* admire it. No matter how it was usually a warning sign that shit was going to go sideways on assignments.

But that wasn't the case now—or ever would be again. He would never see the short stack again after this assignment, or ever again in his life. So truly what harm could *possibly* come from deciding to fuck Izuku right before he retired for good?

It would be poetic to end eight years of frustration with a thorough, animalistic hate fuck.

The heat under Katsuki's collar boiled at the thought of pounding deep into that plush, tight ass. Maybe he could even play with whatever lacy panties the little pervert was wearing. The full fantasy of plowing Izuku straight into that stupid heart shape bed painted effortlessly in his head.

He could hear the labored moans and practically feel the nails scraping down his back as Izuku whimpered under him begging him to fuck into his prostate harder. He could even imagine himself strumming the pleasurable chords of Izuku's body like a violin, making him scream out in high notes for him as he made him cum over and over. This was all entirely possible too since it was clear as day Izuku was attracted to him just as much as he was to him.

Katsuki devilishly smirked and leaned into the sudden desire sparked.

Yeah. He decided he was going to fuck that man within an inch of his life.

☽ ☽ ☽

When Izuku came back from taking his call a while later, he was blushing furiously. The pink hue on his face ran all the way down his neck, stopping right above his clavicle and where his Band-Aid was. His body posture was slightly meek as he hung his head away, cleared his throat and scratched behind his head.

"Sorry about that," Izuku apologized quietly. "I, uh, had to see if there was any update on this assignment. But everything is still set to go."

"That sounds good," Katsuki said.

Without shame, he eye fucked Izuku. The dark crimson eyes translated all the carnal curiosity that was churning inside of Katsuki. At the moment, he truly did not give a flying fuck about discussing killing Moore and Koizumi. He knew they would get to that eventually, but right now he was a little too pleased about the possibility of getting eight years of frustration out.

His eyes stopped directly on Izuku's crotch area.

The freckled hitman stiffened slightly under his hungry gaze. Katsuki's eyes snapped back up and immediately Izuku's gaze skirted off to the side. Katsuki gave a wolfish grin. He always liked them a little shy, it was even more fun to take them apart that way. It was so clear Izuku was considering Katsuki differently now after the deliberate sexual flirting. Green eyes struggled to stay focused on one place in the room. They darted around the lounge, looking at all the photos on the wall.

It nearly seemed like Izuku was weighing on a decision back and forth.

Katsuki grinned wider when he hoped it was the decision on whether or not to have sex with him.

Katsuki decided at that moment to get the ball rolling and help sway the clearly torn man. They could talk business another time, but right now he had a couple positions in mind to get Izuku twisted into.

With full arrogance, Katsuki caught Izuku's gaze again and smirked handsomely. Without breaking eye contact, he moved a hand upwards to unbutton the top three buttons on his shirt.

The material of his shirt fell open fluidly, letting a good eye-full of his well-defined chest show.

Katsuki fucking *loved* how Izuku's pretty green eyes went wide at the sight. Feeling like he got his prey, Katsuki then took a confident step forward towards Izuku, ready to get straight into it. However, he was stunned a bit when Izuku quickly stumbled backwards, keeping the distance between them the same.

"I-It's time for dinner," Izuku said in a hurry, fully flustered. "We should get going before we miss all the good food."

Katsuki raised a brow. He glanced down at his half-exposed chest and back at Izuku with a suggestive expression.

"There's clearly another *cuisine* on the table right now, Izuku. The stupid dining hall food can wait a little bit, don't you think?"

"N-No!" Izuku said quickly.

Katsuki frowned. "No?"

"Ye-Yeah. No. I heard they're having, erm, yakitori and onigiri today. Those are some of my favorite dishes—well o-outside of katsudon! I love katsudon a lot. Hah. H-Have I ever told you that? But I don't think they're going to have any katsudon today. It wasn't on the menu. B-But I still would really like yakitori so let's hurry because I don't want to miss it."

Katsuki became a little confused at the nervous muttering.

"Alright. Sure, whatever, nerd. That's fine but *afterwards*—" He tried to step forward again. But in the same motion, Izuku took another clumsy step backwards, knocking his back against the door like Katsuki was contiguous with something.

"L-Let get going!" Izuku nervously laughed off.

The freckled man quickly turned around in a hurry and fumbled while gripping the golden door handle. He pushed open the wooden door and hurried off in the blink of an eye.

Katsuki stayed there, frozen for a split second.

...What the fuck?

He stared at the empty spot where Izuku just was at with a baffled expression and mental whiplash.

Then it clicked.

Ah. Right. He's probably super fucking shy about casual sex since he's the hopeless romantic type.

Katsuki sighed and carded his hand through his hair. He started to walk out of the private lounge to find Izuku off to the side in the main lounge with a burning red nape. Katsuki dialed back his flirting a bit for now as he approached Izuku. He buttoned back up his shirt when Izuku struggled a bit too much to look at him.

Katsuki let the moment go—for now—as they started on their way to the dining hall. The air between them was thicker, quieter, and this time Izuku didn't reach for his hand. The smaller man was timidly holding his hands behind his back and looking at their shoes as they walked.

By the time they made it to the dining hall, Katsuki concluded fucking Izuku would be a little trickier than he thought. He reflected on how Izuku reacted when he found the condoms in his wallet with a little bit more meaning. Sleeping with people on assignments was probably considered taboo to him, unlike Katsuki's view that it was perfectly fine. But the sexual attraction was there and Izuku wasn't that dumb to think it wasn't.

All this probably meant Katsuki had to do some work to get the dork out of his shell—which was fine.

Katsuki liked a challenge and if Izuku was anything, it was fucking challenging.

They got their food and true to Izuku's little weird ramble, the man stacked fucking yakitori high on his plate. Katsuki took a couple of pieces of meat, vegetables, and rice for his plate as they walked over to their color group.

Along the way, he could see Izuku deliberate on whether or not to hold his hand—and for the first time Katsuki decided to be the one to do so. He reached for Izuku's free hand and fluidly intertwined their fingers like he had been taught, and he could fucking *feel* the little gears in Izuku's head working overtime.

"Hey Bakugous!" Mina welcomed them as they sat down.

Katsuki and Izuku easily said hello to everyone, particularly keeping an eye on Shouto and Inasa who gave them ignorantly happy smiles. The pair of cops were chatting and talking about the food around downtown Nago they sampled today. As they talked about all the different sweets they devoured, everyone began eating their meals.

Izuku tried to let go of his hand, but Katsuki didn't let him. He halfway considered it, but no. Katsuki was priming Izuku for fucking which meant the little bastard wasn't going to shy away from holding his goddamn hand *now*. Especially not after being so nice and dropping all those hints.

At the tightened hold, Izuku stiffened slightly and looked at Katsuki in a baffled way. The blond hitman raised a brow and took a solid bite of the meat skewered on the stick without breaking eye contact.

Izuku's stare intensified.

“Bakugous, did you guys catch up on sleep or do anything fun today?” Eijiro asked with his pointy smile. “Mina and I found this sick spot around the hotel for bowling! I had no clue there was so much stuff jam packed in here. It’s so endless.”

“We played pool and hung out around the lounge area,” Izuku answered. He smiled happily and squeezed Katsuki’s hand in his. “It was fun. Actually, this whole trip has been fun. I almost don’t want this trip to end.” The end of Izuku’s sentence tapered off into a sullen tone as though he was truly sad about it.

It made Katsuki wonder if that sentiment was real or fake.

“Me either,” Shouto tacked on with a distant tone. “There’s still…a lot of unfinished things to do here.”

The code in the detective’s words made Katsuki resist rolling his eyes. Of fucking *course* the goddamn cop would speak like he was in a television show and some third party was viewing them. Where did he think he was? ‘Law & Order: SVU?’

“When do you all check out by the way?” Katsuki asked, cutting straight into the info they needed before his patience wore thin. “We leave in a couple of days and I’m hoping we’re all together until the end of the trip.”

“Ah, sorry bro, we’re actually leaving in about two days.” Eijiro smiled apologetically. “We have a fitness leadership workshop we signed up for! But I agree it’s been fun.”

“We leave in four days,” Momo said. She pushed around the food on her plate a bit. “Todorokis. How about you two?”

“We leave in five days,” Shouto said smoothly. He was unsuspecting that he possibly gave away a bit of information that he and Izuku needed. They had five days to kill Moore now—which meant to Katsuki he also had five days to get into Izuku’s pants. “We have a big event coming up after that time, so it would be nice to enjoy the facilities here. You never know when they’re going to get shut down or if you’ll be able to come back.”

Katsuki resisted rolling his eyes again.

Yeah. This guy definitely believed he was a guest star on ‘Law & Order: SVU.’

“So true!” Mina agreed, clearly not aware of the plot happening. “I was telling Ei the same thing. This is probably the only time we’ll be in Paradise like this so we should live it up to the fullest! I made a fun checklist of stuff we could do as a paradise crew before Ei and I leave!”

All the people at the table murmured in agreement and Izuku perked up. “That sounds great! What’s first on your list, Mina?”

“Well, the day after tomorrow there’s going to be a fun pop-up amusement park in downtown Nago,” Mina replied. She pulled a neatly folded pink paper out of his bra and read from it.

“It’s called Japan’s Traveling Carnival Park. It’s been touring the country for a while now and it’s on its yearly stop to Okinawa. I always wanted to go! It could be so much fun.”

Katsuki’s whole body uncomfortably stiffened.

Japan’s Traveling Carnival Park.

What were the fucking chances?

Katsuki frowned a bit, unsure if he wanted to actually attend that. He was still clearly affected by those memories and going to the exact place where shit pivoted possibly wasn’t the smartest choice.

Right as Katsuki was about to reject that suggestion, Izuku spoke up. His big green eyes were wide, sparkling and his hand holding Katsuki’s squeezed affectionately.

“Really?” Izuku gasped. His thumb affectionately caressed Katsuki’s skin again. “That’s perfect! Kac—*Taro* and I always wanted to go to one together.”

The sense of hopefulness in Izuku’s words didn’t sit all the way right in Katsuki’s head.

That tone wasn’t fake.

He looked at the other hitman bizarrely, and when Izuku turned towards him, he appeared like a kid in a candy shop. Katsuki’s words ran dry like a barren river when he looked at Izuku’s big green eyes and curly hair at that moment. All the uncomfortable memories of the childhood separation came flooding back in. Big, green eyes and dark, curly hair.

When Katsuki didn’t utter a word—Izuku’s excitement faltered as though he had remembered something.

“B-But only if he wants to go,” Izuku retracted quietly. He turned his gaze away from Katsuki and put on a fake smile. “Taro isn’t really big on crowds like that.”

“...It’s fine, we can go.” The words were pulled out of him the longer he looked at Izuku’s big green eyes.

His faux husband peered at him curiously at the sudden shift in demeanor. Everyone else at the table looked overjoyed at the idea about the carnival.

“Alrighty! Carnival it is!” Eijiro said excitedly and high-fived his wife.

The conversation was swept into Mina’s list, going over all the things she had researched them to all do together. Izuku melted into the flowing river of conversation, periodically glancing at him as though to make sure he was alright.

But for an unknown reason, no. Katsuki wasn’t entirely alright. The memory of when he was separated from his unknown childhood best friend sparked up at the idea of attending that carnival. He could perfectly feel the cold, see that blinking ‘C’ on the pink, neon sign and hear the time tick away on his little red watch. Katsuki ended up wading in an awkward

space. He distantly listened in on the various conversations at the round table as he struggled not to zone out.

Katsuki grew quiet and shifted into eavesdropping while eating his food.

To entertain himself, the odd feeling hitman glanced up at the mural on the dome shaped ceiling. He admired the beautifully tragic painting once again. His eyes kept dancing across all the panels, soaking in the details. He looked back to that strange last panel of the angel of death and the lover who took a bite of the venomous apple.

“I won a random assortment of comics today at some raffle today actually,” Jirou mentioned offhandedly to Izuku. The mention of comics caught Katsuki’s attention a bit. “I don’t really want them, and I don’t think they’ll fit in my suitcase. Do you or Taro like comics?”

“Oh yeah! We both really love them,” Izuku answered easily. He grinned wide and there was a look of content on his face like he was thinking of some far-off memory. “His favorite superhero is actually All Might. If you have any of those comics, we’ll take them.”

Katsuki stopped chewing his food mid-bite.

Did I tell him that?

He frowned. He was really unsure he mentioned that at all. He hadn’t thought about comics in fucking ages, and he was positive he hadn’t told Izuku that All Might had been his favorite character. Red eyes cut to Izuku a tad when that phantom feeling from earlier in the day returned.

“Oh, retro! Nice,” Jirou said with a thumbs up. “Luckily for you, they are! I’ll make sure to drop them off at your room later.”

“Perfect! Thank you so much!” Izuku happily giggled. He looked as though he was genuinely happy to hear that.

Katsuki searched his sharp memory for the information he had given to the other hitman.

He was pretty careful about what he revealed and didn’t reveal considering he still had to keep in mind Izuku worked for a potential rival company similar to his. However, Katsuki was nearly damn sure he *never* fucking mentioned All Might of all things. Maybe Izuku guessed? But All Might comics were so fucking niche. They weren’t particularly popular enough for even someone with Izuku’s aim to metaphorically hit a bullseye like that.

It was weird.

The conversation veered off into something disinteresting and Katsuki tried his best to shake off the whispering phantom that was attached to his skin. He felt the ghostly hands of the past grip his shoulders and heard a whisper in his ear again. The voice was full of blaring static: *“It’s ~~Izuku~~.”*

“You’re so awesome, Hiroji!” Momo laughed in the distance.

Izuku's fake name clashed harshly in his mind against the unknown words the phantom memory was whispering. It felt deeply wrong, and tugged at his skin and forced chilling goosebumps to ignite.

Katsuki lightly shook his head, ignoring the way Izuku's false name caused him discomfort.

☽ ☽ ☽

They ended up going out with the group after dinner. Everyone was high energy and decided to go hang out at the beach together. It was a fun time as they all set up their beach towels and changed into bathing suits. Their entire Paradise Crew was enjoying the relaxing setting as they watched a couple of surfers handle the large incoming waves.

However, when the sun began to set, Katsuki could see Izuku was struggling to stay awake.

It had been a long day and even to Katsuki the idea of a bed was appealing. The freckled hitman struggled to keep up with the high energy of the group and periodically Katsuki caught him closing his eyes for a bit under the ruse of 'resting his eyes.'

When he caught Izuku closing his eyes under their beach umbrella for a fourth fucking time, Katsuki decided it was time to go.

He insisted to the knuckle headed freckled man that they should go head back to their room. The first time he suggested it, Izuku rejected it. Izuku blushed and gave a sheepish smile. He shifted over on the sand, still acting as though Katsuki was contagious and that he was shy about what had happened earlier. But when the blond man caught him dozing off against his shoulder, Izuku agreed then that a bed did sound nice.

They said goodbye to their Paradise Crew as they headed back towards the hotel.

The entire walk back to their room, Katsuki fiddled quietly with the pink hotel keycard. He looked at the little hearts and palm tree icons that were painted on the plastic surface.

He eyed Izuku who was utterly quiet. But if the silence was from shyness or tiredness, Katsuki wasn't sure. What he did know though, was that he was getting rid of that pillow barrier tonight. Katsuki plotted in his head that he would fake some accidental cuddles, spoon the fuck out of Izuku, get some more grinding in and that would easily lead to a morning jerk off session. Then *boom*. Hate sex. Easy as fucking cake.

He swiped the card to the suite with a slight eagerness.

They walked into the room and the first thing Izuku did was rub his eyes.

The smaller man was clearly tethered on the edge of a deep sleep. Izuku proceeded to stretch in a way that reminded Katsuki of a fox as he started towards gathering his belongings to use the bathroom for his night routine.

Katsuki grinned a bit, realizing this was his chance to set the stage. When Izuku's back was turned, digging in his suitcase, Katsuki walked over to the bed. He began to discreetly move the pillow barrier off the bed while Izuku was distracted.

“You’re really fucking sleepy huh?” Katsuki asked. Izuku nodded with his eyes closed.

“Extremely, I can barely think straight,” Izuku muttered with a light yawn. He grabbed a fresh set of pajamas and a towel and started to make his way to the shower. “If I’m not out in twenty minutes, please come check on me. I sometimes fall asleep in the shower when I’m tired like this.”

“Will do. Good night, Izuku,” Katsuki said slyly as he moved the last pillow off the bed.

“Goodnight, Kacchan,” Izuku replied tiredly.

Both men froze.

“...What did you call me?” Katsuki said slowly.

He dropped the red pillow to the ground and rounded on Izuku whose eyes were now wide awake. The freckled man’s mouth hung open in shock as they stared at each other in horror.

“Izuku. What the *fuck* did you just call me?”

“I-I called you Kacchan. But Katsuki, w-wait—”

“—Why the hell would you call me Kacchan?” Katsuki nearly growled and he looked at Izuku with deep disgust. “Don’t call me that, Izuku. What the fuck?”

A piercing spear of hurt cut straight through Katsuki and an inexplicable gut punch of betrayal twisted the inside of his stomach.

He knew they weren’t exactly *friends,* but it felt like a stab in the chest to have Izuku bring that up after they had been getting along so well. He stared with burning eyes at the man in front of him as his throat started to close up like someone really was choking him. He was truly regretting letting that shit out during the camping trip, but he didn’t think Izuku would be twisted enough to call him the very nickname he told them all about.

Then Izuku’s big, green eyes softened.

They softened with fucking *pity*.

Katsuki’s sharp features twisted into repulsion and his heart began to hammer out of control.

Kacchan. Kacchan. Fucking *Kacchan*. The sound of that simple, innocent nickname kicked up all the buried emotions sitting at the bottom of Katsuki’s core. Suddenly he was being crushed underneath the guilt he felt for leaving and the hurt that came from the separation. All the ugly, feelings of loneliness that he wanted to ignore sneered in his face reminding him how broken he was.

“Kacchan, wait. Please don’t get mad. I can explain—”

“—No,” Katsuki rejected instantly in a deep hiss. His defenses shot up out of his control. He shook his head and marched up to Izuku with a blazen look of fury, ready to put the other

man in his place immediately. “You do not get to tell me not to be mad about you using that nickname after I was *vulnerable*. Don’t ever call me Kacchan again, you fucking *creep*.”

Izuku flinched for the first time Katsuki ever witnessed but it didn’t stop him.

“Where the fuck do you think you get off calling me that after I fucking told everyone why I was given that nickname? *Hah*?” Katsuki hissed. His voice slipped into a louder volume. “Do you think that it’s fucking funny? Are you that goddamn twisted in the head?”

“No, of course not.” Izuku’s face crumbled, his lips slightly trembled as though he was struggling to say something more. Pain fanned across his face as he stared up at the angry blond looming over him. “I didn’t mean it like that. It slipped out.”

The color drained from Izuku’s face as he stayed petrified there gazing at Katsuki with pity. Pity he didn’t fucking want, and he didn’t need—*especially* from Izuku. Katsuki nostrils flared as he leaned into Izuku’s face with a nasty scowl.

“Listen to me carefully because I don’t deal with *bullshit* like that,” Katsuki threatened. “People like you don’t get to use that nickname, so you need to erase it from your goddamn memory.”

“People like me?” Izuku echoed. His face warped into a raw, vulnerable expression. “What does *that* mean?”

“It means *fucked up* people like *you*.” Katsuki used his words to dig into him and twist like a knife plunged deep. “People who don’t fucking flinch when I snap a man’s neck. Fucked up people who murder a man in cold blood in front of another. Fucked up people like you who have been a goddamn *thorn* in my side for years. You don’t get to corrupt that memory for me with how fucked up *you* are because I already am fucked up enough to taint it *myself*.”

An unmistakable aggrieved look eclipsed Izuku’s face. His delicate freckled features twisted, clearly wounded. Big, green eyes were struggling not to let tears fall and he appeared as though he had been violently slapped.

Katsuki only then realized that his own eyes were prickling with tears. They stung, and pushed at the burning rims of his eyes for the first time since he was thirteen.

The silence between them swelled with hurt and neither man moved.

Izuku’s lips were quivering. Katsuki’s fists were curled. When Izuku’s hurt expression became too much, Katsuki glanced away—but his eyes landed directly on Izuku’s black violin case.

His heart clutched painfully as all the past memories started tumbling forward.

It all hurt a little too much suddenly. Katsuki’s chest heaved slightly when his breathing convulsed. The strange phantom feeling from earlier gripped him again as he looked at the dings and scrapes on Izuku’s violin case; it was then that Katsuki decided he needed to be alone. Far away from Izuku and his big, green eyes.

“I’m going to go get some air, don’t wait up for me,” Katsuki whispered. His chest tightened to the point he felt pain.

Izuku didn’t respond, and Katsuki didn’t glance to see if he was still staring at him.

He grabbed his keycard and marched straight back out from where he came.

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki walked along the beach under the full moon by himself until he lost track of time.

It was well into the witching hours and there wasn’t a single soul awake with him now. He took off his shoes and walked steadily on the beach to calm down. This was one of the only things he could do to calm down—take time away from everyone to empty his head. He was beyond thankful no one else was around as he blinked back tears, preventing them from falling.

The entirety of the beach was like a ghost town. But while solitude usually was a remedy for his disharmony, Katsuki felt alone. He felt far more alone than he usually did as he sunk his feet into the soft sand.

He glanced back at the hotel that was shaded under the tall palm trees swaying with the wind. From this distance, Katsuki could see the white and yellow window squares in the high skyscraper complex. Some windows were dark, signaling whoever was inside was asleep while others were still illuminated showing people’s silhouettes.

He glanced up at one particular one, trying to see if he could see Izuku still awake, but the light was officially off.

He didn’t know why he cared—he shouldn’t.

Izuku so casually threw around a nickname he had no right of using. However, the pained emotion that had plagued Izuku’s deep green eyes haunted Katsuki. Izuku seemed beyond hurt and Katsuki wondered if he should’ve said what he said at the end about Izuku being *fucked up*. Katsuki sighed and pushed the heels of his palms into his eye sockets.

He stopped walking, sinking in the sand a bit. The wind howled and blew through his hair. Katsuki turned his sullen eyes to look out at the moonlit ocean waves. The subtle lighting made them appear more fragile and soothing. All the glittering reflections from the city lights, and the moon danced in the ocean like tiny stars were drifting on its surface.

After another hour, Katsuki felt himself finally calm again.

He looked down at his black watch and realized it was 04:44. Izuku was probably asleep, which was what Katsuki wanted. He could go back upstairs and build that pillow barrier again and they could act as though this never happened. After hearing Izuku call him Kacchan and look at him with such deep pity, all Katsuki really wanted now was to finish off the assignment and part ways.

He walked back to the hotel, entering the empty lobby. The checkered marble floors were shining, and the usually packed hotel was entirely empty in a ghostly way. He walked to the elevators and pressed the heart shaped up button. As he was waiting, a gentle breeze blew through the open window to the side. It called him as the sheer white curtain wafted with the flow. Katsuki was going to disregard it like normal, however with the drifting wind came a soft distant melody.

Katsuki frowned when it evoked a sense of ominous nostalgia, and he could have sworn his ears were playing tricks on him. The sound of a distant violin playing in the night called to him and he was compelled to walk over to the windowsill. He gripped the ledge and peered his head out to be met with nothing but the hedges of the rose garden maze in the back of the hotel.

The melody was faint. Faint as a dying ember struggling for oxygen, but Katsuki could hear it ever so slightly. He listened closer and he could've sworn that it sounded similar to—

No.

It couldn't be.

The phantom holding onto him returned and Katsuki pushed away from the window, with slightly shaky hands.

The elevator dinged for him, and the doors slid wide with a creek, but Katsuki rushed past.

His heart began to pound quicker in tempo as he thought about that song. A unique song that, as far as he thought, only three people knew about. He found himself heading out the large white doors of the back of the hotel to follow the calling of the soft violin. The feeling of a phantom spirit guided him by pulling his wrist as he thought about everything that came with that song.

He thought about big, green eyes. The white violin. He thought about the cracked, forgotten statue of the angel and the leaning abandoned church. He could even feel the chill of the winter winds and suddenly Katsuki felt like he wasn't in Okinawa anymore. He was transported back to the dense city of Tokyo, lost and confused.

Katsuki wandered around the dark rose garden, searching for the source until he could hear it was coming from inside the maze. Scarlet eyes glanced at the beautiful vine covered entrance that seemed more like an enchanting portal to another realm.

Suddenly, he could hear the distant memory of two giggling boys playing tag. Then his mind supplied for him the unclear vision of his savior, eagerly wanting to play tag. The blurry faced boy stopped, turned to him, and smiled through the fog. The memory of his savior happily gestured for him to follow into the maze and then ran off.

Katsuki proceeded in carefully, feeling like he had finally lost it.

He went down the winding, twisting paths that nearly felt like navigating the labyrinth inside his own mind. He followed the sound of that melody and could see glimpses of the memory

of his blurry faced savior giggling and running all around the corners of the maze.

He tried to follow the sound but was met with a handful of dead ends—like he always was.

Then gradually, the melody picked up in tempo and Katsuki began to trust his gut. He walked with the beat through the intricate maze, purely guided by listening to that haunting song.

The closer he got to the source, the more real it became.

Each note was played exactly how he remembered it to be and then gradually more memories followed.

The phantom figure of the blurry faced boy running through the maze grew clearer. With every new note, Katsuki could clearly see a new feature.

He saw dark, curly hair that was now dark, green curly hair. He saw light freckles that were still faint. He saw honeydew skin and two dimples. Katsuki's heart started to beat erratically as he wandered deeper into the maze and his memory. With each step the phantom boy felt more real. Then when he was around the corner from the mystery violin player, the phantom of his savior, turned to him.

The vision of the boy was now perfectly clear, and he gestured for Katsuki to follow him as he ran off towards the sound of the violin.

Katsuki followed the melody, fully compelled. When he rounded the corner, he stopped right under the vine covered archway that opened to the marble fountain of the woman with a vase. Then his eyes landed on a single, lone figure that was hunched over.

Sitting there underneath the statue was Izuku, playing *The Dance of The Love Birds* with the same white violin from his childhood.

All the oxygen left Katsuki's lungs as he watched in a trance. Izuku's body swayed with the music and he treated the ivory violin like it was a natural extension of his body. His eyes were closed, brows pinched together and his facial expression was purely vulnerable as he played. But what was the most haunting thing was that Izuku played the chords exactly like the old violinist used to: with a frightening sense of passion.

Then the phantom whispered into Katsuki's ear once more. However, this time there was no static as the memory intertwined with the eerie melody:

"Can I call you Kacchan?"

"Ye-Yeah. Kacchan works. What's your name?"

"It's Izuku."

"…Izuku," Katsuki whispered uneasily into the dark night. "It was you?"

The song abruptly stopped and Izuku whipped his head harshly towards Katsuki.

Twin bloodshot eyes stared at each other in shock.



By Mal on Twitter

Chapter End Notes

Let me know what you think below if you have any thoughts, comments, or screams. No preview this week because it's basically all spoilers.

Side note, the song I repeatedly link for The Dance of The Love Birds is called "Passacaglia violin and viola". It's in the Deathly Beautiful spotify playlist as the 6th song listed :) I can't compose music but in my mind that suits it going forward in this story. I hope you like it as much as I do! Thank you so much for reading! ^^

Chapter 8: Moderato

Chapter Summary

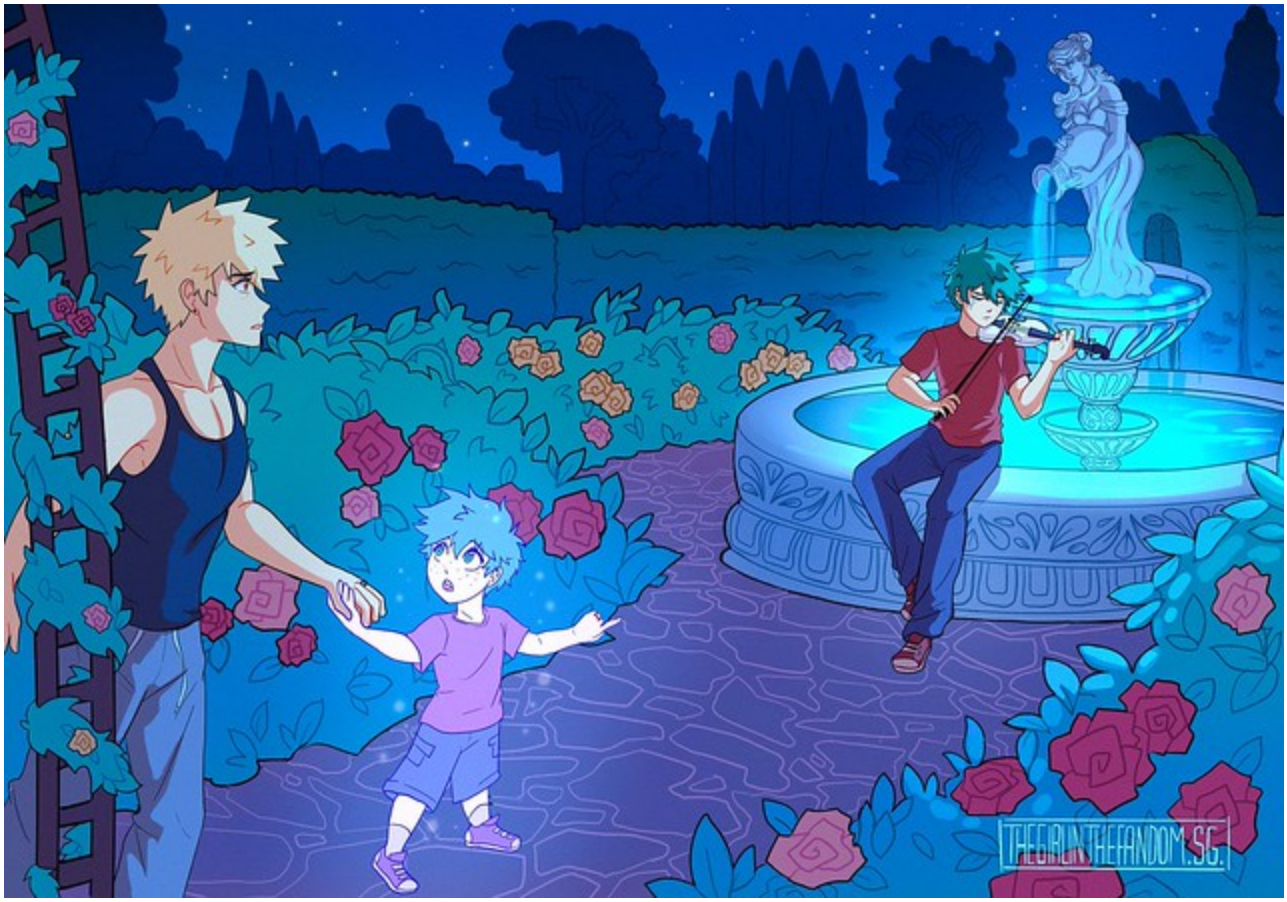
> Moderato (Tempo): In a moderate tempo. Medium paced.

Chapter Notes

> Helloooo! Welcome back to a fun chapter. First, thank you to Luna for betaing like always. She's got my whole heart and she's my moon and stars. I hope you enjoy this chapter!
>
> Secondly, thank you to Stephanie! She drew the beautiful art featured in this chapter. Please give her a follow on instagram or twitter.
>
> Lastly, please take a look at the last chapter. There was art added back there too! There was a lot of really wonderful fan art made in the last two weeks for this fic and my heart is so full.
>
> Thank you guys so much for enjoying this fic, I love you all and Happy New Year!

> **Warnings: Mentions of child abuse. Mentions of child neglect and drug use.**

See the end of the chapter for more notes



By TheGirlInTheFandom

Chapter 8 - Moderato

.

.

.

"…Izuku," Katsuki whispered uneasily into the dark night. "It was you?"

The song abruptly stopped and Izuku whipped his head harshly towards Katsuki.

Twin bloodshot eyes stared at each other in shock.

Everything in Katsuki's stomach knotted until he felt like he was on a sinking boat. He was drowning deeper and deeper in ghastly realization by the second. He even struggled to breathe as it all came flooding in, forcing all the air out of his lungs. Even though the song had halted, it lingered behind in his head—somehow even louder than before.

The rise and fall of that melody from so long ago trickled all over his thoughts like gentle rain. It made every single one of his distant childhood memories come barging in, flashing at

lightning speed right before his eyes. But this time they were clear. They were crystal fucking clear and full of freckles, green eyes, and dark, curly hair.

Katsuki took a hesitant step towards Izuku, eyes wide in disbelief.

Then like a startled animal, Izuku lurched backwards as if he got too close to a flame. Without taking another second, he began to stumble over himself and scrambled to leave. His trembling hands clumsily tossed the violin and bow back into the worn-down case. He snapped the case shut with force.

Katsuki's eyes widened even more, and his heart rate sped up in tempo. Izuku was leaving. Izuku was trying to *leave*. Katsuki began running towards him, reaching out a hand for the juddering man.

"W-Wait—*Izuku*—"

The name clashed in his head. Immediately, visions of the past and present struggled for dominance.

The two versions of Izuku in his mind blended together as well as water and oil. On the surface sat the current version of Izuku that he knew: the bloodied hitman who he tousled with for eight years. Under the surface was the version of young Izuku: the one who sheltered him, bathed him, and showered him with affection. The version that helped him survive and left a note that said he—

Katsuki's throat clutched on that last thought.

The moment Katsuki drew too close, Izuku darted away into the dark maze. Katsuki shot out a hand to grab Izuku and stop him, but the fabric of the silky shirt slipped past his fingertips as if he failed at catching a ghost.

"Izuku!" Katsuki called out with desperation. His voice cracked at the end, and he didn't know why but he knew he couldn't let Izuku go—he *couldn't*. "Izuku—fuck. *Wait*—"

His body operated like it was being jerked around by the hands of fate as he sprung forward to seize the frantically retreating man. Both of his hands forcefully grabbed Izuku's arms. His fingers dug into the other man, checking to make sure this wasn't a dream, but also to stop him from fleeing. He clung on to Izuku as though he was his last lifeline.

Without an ounce of hesitation, Izuku tried to twist out of his tight hold. The violin case dropped to the ground, shaking the earth beneath them as though they were a natural disaster together. And maybe they were.

The case snapped back open, and the violin came tumbling out the second they began to tousle about.

Katsuki's pleas fell on Izuku's seemingly deaf ears. No matter how much he begged for Izuku to be still, it felt as though Izuku struggled more against him. It became clear that Izuku had no intention of staying when their scuffle became more severe. Katsuki hissed as they began

pushing and pulling on each other in a familiar way that they had in the last eight years. But this time it was somberly different as tears clutched the edges of their eyes.

Every time Katsuki thought he had Izuku, the other man would push against his chest with all his strength. But Katsuki couldn't be budged. He couldn't be pushed away. Not right now. Not after so long.

"G-Get off of me," Izuku's broken voice begged.

Katsuki gritted his teeth and shook his head. "J-Just wait a moment—"

"—No, let me go you *asshole*—"

The next few moments were as big of a blur as inside of Katsuki's mind. Izuku harshly yanked himself away one more time and tripped in the process and Katsuki's grip on him refused to let go. The two of them went toppling down on the soft grass with Katsuki on top of Izuku trying to pin him to stay still. They struggled back and forth like harsh, clashing waves in a storm.

It was only when Katsuki wrapped his arms around Izuku from behind, restraining the man's arms to his side, did they finally stop.

The pounding of Katsuki's erratic heart deafened his hearing. His pulse was racing out of his control, and he could feel Izuku's was too.

Synchronized heavy, uneven breathing filled the night air as the stars and moon shone down on them. Katsuki kept his arms securely wrapped around Izuku, feeling as though he had finally caught the phantom haunting his past. Izuku had his head down, and his hands were forcefully clutching the blades of grass until he uprooted several of them.

"Please." Izuku's voice was hoarse and heavy. "Let go."

"I can't," Katsuki replied. His voice was rickety. His hands were shaking. He barely recognized himself as he gaped at the ground below them in shock. His mind was clouded by the sound of two boys giggling, and the warm feeling of his forgotten savior's touch. Izuku's touch. "I can't let go. I've been trying my whole life, but I *can't*."

His grip on Izuku tightened as he hugged the other man closer.

They stayed there, frozen in place.

Katsuki didn't know how much time passed as he struggled to process what was happening. The leaves on the hedges rustled. The sound of the running fountain echoed between them. They both stayed there, unmoving as their breathing calmed down.

His mind obsessively repeated the same memories over and over again. Dimples. Freckles. Green hair. Green eyes. Pretty fucking green eyes that looked at him like he was the world.

When it seemed like an eternity passed, Izuku hesitantly lifted a hand. He touched where Katsuki was sinking his calloused fingers into him. It burned slightly. The grip was nearly

painful and all the way desperate. Until that, Katsuki hadn't registered that his own body was shaking. His hand trembled with rocky unease as Izuku's warm fingers covered it.

They silently communicated when words failed.

Izuku touched his hand in a way that mimicked water being thrown over a raging flame. The burn of anxiousness smothered out slowly, and Katsuki relaxed his hold. His arms went slack ever so slightly as he started to come down from the intensity of the moment. Izuku did too. Katsuki didn't let go all the way, only enough for Izuku to breathe again and gasp for a large gulp of air.

"Is…is it really you?" Katsuki questioned with a splintering crack. "Was it you that year in Tokyo?"

"Y-Yes."

That single word simultaneously pierced him and comforted him.

It was Izuku. It was really him.

The freckled man turned around in his arms, facing him. Katsuki released him and placed his forearms on either side of Izuku's head as they locked eyes up close. Katsuki threatened to spill tears as he studied the person from his past closer, trying to etch all Izuku's features into his mind.

Neither one of them moved as they laid there with their faces twisted in disbelief.

They inspected one another quietly. Shock, longing, and hurt melted together in endless green and red. There were so many emotions spilling out that Katsuki's heart clutched trying to process it all. The pair of long-lost friends gazed at each other for several moments as though the other was a walking daydream. Or a nightmare. Katsuki wasn't sure which one this would classify as.

"Did you know?" Katsuki asked. "This whole time?"

"No." Izuku shook his head and screwed his eyes shut. "I figured it out at the campfire when you mentioned being called 'Kacchan'."

Katsuki's heart fell into his stomach so fast he became nauseous.

The campfire.

He thought back on what Izuku had said about fate. Specifically what he said about being destined to cross paths with another soul on this hell hole earth. Now those words felt heavy with deep implications as he looked at the person underneath him. This should be impossible.

He struggled to say something. Anything.

He wasn't sure *what* he wanted to say as he stayed paralyzed in place, caging Izuku in. All he knew is that he didn't want Izuku to flee again. A twist in his stomach grew at the idea of

releasing Izuku, terrified that this was all a vivid hallucination.

“Why didn’t you say something sooner?” Katsuki asked past the lump clogging his throat.

“I—I don’t know,” Izuku whispered. He opened his eyes and set his vulnerable gaze on Katsuki. “I-I thought about saying something. All night and all day today, I wanted to tell you, but I didn’t know *how*. E-Especially after all this time. It was messing with me. Like *really* messing with my head. You have to be feeling weird about all of this too, aren’t you?”

“Of course. It feels like—” *fate*.

Katsuki swallowed that word.

It was thick in his throat and tasted bitter yet sweet. He stared at Izuku’s watery eyes, and his heart hammered to the point he thought it would break free from its holding.

“It feels like a really big coincidence,” Katsuki finished, tapering off into a whisper.

Izuku gazed at him harder. Viridian eyes flickered all around his face, examining his nose, his lips and even the soft way his blond locks of hair fell forward.

“Yeah. A coincidence.”

Silence fell again.

Katsuki leaned away. His heart had finally climbed down from the mountain of anxiety it was perched on and he could think straight again. He fell to Izuku’s side while keeping his eyes still trained on him. It was as if he could barely look away, afraid that if he did this would all vanish.

On the other hand, Izuku stared up at the sky as though there was further explanation up above them.

All the memories of their intermingled lives danced about. It was almost too much to think about—or even accept. How had they recollided *here*, in Okinawa of all places? The very same location they said they would run away too when they were kids—

Izuku turned his gentle gaze towards him with the softest expression he had ever seen. He wondered what was going through Izuku’s head. Was he happy? Was he sad? Was he in *shock*—or was he struggling to stay awake after going so long without proper rest. Big green eyes blinked tiredly; a sleep deprived lag so clearly present.

Katsuki’s heart squeezed without warning in a way he wasn’t prepared to tackle.

“We should go back upstairs,” Katsuki whispered eventually. He was still unsure if this was all real.

Izuku wordlessly agreed, no longer putting up a fight.

They both stood up, regarding the other quietly. Katsuki's limbs suddenly were awkward. He didn't know what to do with himself as he became hyper aware of his whole body. He watched how Izuku carefully picked up the fallen violin and bow. Both their eyes lingered on it for a moment, looking at all the cracks it had. Then Izuku placed it back into the case with care and sealed it tightly.

After that, they walked back to their room side by side.

As they made their way back through the empty foyer, all Katsuki had was questions. Boundless questions that were now plaguing his thoughts. He tried to connect the past and present Izukus to each other, but he was clearly missing the middleman.

How did someone as nice as Izuku wind up a cold-blooded killer? Just like he had.

What had happened in those ten years? Izuku said he did this job for survival. So, what the hell did that mean? Did he need money? Did he need food? Did something go terribly wrong in his life? Did someone die? The questions kept coming as his imagination cruelly filled in the gaps.

Katsuki's migraine intensified until thick, acidic bile burned his throat.

When they made it back to the hotel room, a mountain of questions sat stacked on the forefront of his mind. He wanted to blurt them out, but as he looked at Izuku, his lips sealed tight. Izuku's shoulders were hunched. His bloodshot eyes looked like they were set ablaze with tiny red veins crawling across the whites of his eyeballs like spiderwebs.

His faux husband stared at the baby pink walls and heart shaped bed as if they really were in limbo. It all seemed dissimilar. Before it was as though the overly lovesick room was taunting Katsuki, reminding him how he was stuck in this gimmicky paradise and that love would always be something within reach but not something he could touch. Now it felt dull. Full of nothing but a facade and Katsuki realized he was so goddamn blind.

This whole time. This whole time *Izuku* was here.

They changed into their pajamas without another word, stealing glances at the other in the moonlit room. When Izuku climbed back into the bed he was awkwardly fiddling with his fingers, staring at the spinning ceiling fan. Katsuki made a move to climb into the bed as well, feeling absolutely drained. However, his foot stepped on the soft pile of pillows that he had removed earlier. He halted.

He surveyed them.

He hesitantly reached down but stopped.

Izuku watched him closely the whole time, the fidgeting with his hands halted.

Katsuki sighed and suddenly the pillow barrier seemed incredibly stupid. He climbed under the covers without a word, and they laid side by side again. Katsuki folded his hands over the

edge of the cover and eventually turned his head towards Izuku. Nearly luminescent green eyes stared back at him like he was a complex problem to solve.

“You’re not going to put the pillow barrier back up?” Izuku asked.

The clicking of the ceiling fan filled the room. Katsuki toyed with the idea, but the new clarity in his mind wouldn’t allow him to even fathom doing that.

“No, no barrier anymore,” Katsuki said exhaustedly.

Izuku gave him a tired smile, obviously struggling to stay awake. Almost like he was afraid to fall asleep. A part of Katsuki’s heart tugged and twisted at that. Maybe Izuku was scared this was all a dream too. He hadn’t considered that there was a possibility Izuku had the same fears as him. Maybe he even had the same nightmares.

Eventually, Izuku fell fast asleep. Katsuki became slightly memorized by the gentle rise and fall of his chest as his breathing evened out.

“Goodnight,” Katsuki whispered.

He clutched the covers and hoped when he awoke, that this would all still be real.

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki found himself dreaming again.

He floated into his younger self softly, in contrast to previous times when he was hurled into it. Everything was different now. Everything was softer. Clearer. The edges of his vision were no longer vignetted black. Instead, they were stained bright magenta and there was a warmhearted touch wrapped around him. It was as if he was being hugged in a blanket someone had hand stitched together, solely for him. He stared around at the scene, and everything was in sharp, high definition.

It was the middle of spring. The pink flowers on the trees had blossomed and there were birds up above circling round and round, chirping. He could almost remember how the pollen in the air tickled his nose. People were walking around in bright colored shorts, dresses and sandals, laughing in melodic ways.

He was in his plaza again. The way it had been before the construction. He was standing underneath the statue of the broken angel. He gazed up at it, looking into the stone eyes that stared back at him in an ominous manner. Beneath it was the looney old man. He was smiling with all his crooked teeth, happily playing the violin. The song he was performing was as soft and gentle as the spring breeze.

There was a subtle tug on Katsuki’s hand.

He looked down to where a smaller hand was holding his and saw the two fabric rings. He could remember smiling, enjoying how they matched. He also remembered seeing the way young Izuku smiled softly at him.

“I like being married to you, Kacchan,” young Izuku whispered like it was a secret. He swung their intertwined hands and giggled. A cherry-colored blush adored his round face. “This is the most fun I’ve ever had.”

Katsuki remembered laughing as he swung their arms together in sync with Izuku.

“Me too, Izuku.”

Young Izuku kissed him on the cheek then kissed him quickly on the mouth. They smiled shyly at each other as Katsuki moved to steal another kiss. But before he could, there was a loud sound from up above. It mimicked roaring thunder without the clash of lightning. Katsuki glanced up at the clear blue sky, confused. Then slowly, the banging grew louder and louder. With each bang, the pink tinted dream started to fade.

Katsuki returned his eyes to young Izuku who was smiling at him fondly. Izuku whispered ‘goodbye’ as the dream started to end. The fingers intertwined with his slowly faded and Izuku’s hand fazed through him. Sadness trickled into Katsuki as he tried to desperately grab it again, but it was useless. He watched helplessly as it all dulled to white.

Young Izuku’s smile was the last thing he saw.

The banging continued and Katsuki sluggishly blinked awake.

When he became more aware of his surroundings, the loud thumping could be distinguished as knocking. Katsuki groaned slightly because he was getting really fucking sick of motherfuckers banging on their door.

He opened his tired eyes all the way and the first thing he saw was Izuku. The other man was still sound asleep, mildly snoring. His hand was very close to Katsuki’s on the bed, and he looked a single scootch away from cuddling him. Somehow, they had moved closer on the mattress throughout the night, their bodies turned inward and knees touching lightly.

The ruby encrusted ring on Izuku’s finger caught the morning light from the window. The sight of that wedding ring made Katsuki’s heart skip unannounced. He looked down at his own hand. He stared at their matching rings with all their glorious irony.

The loud knocking continued and broke Katsuki out of his sleepy daze.

He grunted slightly as he carefully climbed out of bed, doing his best not to wake Izuku. He walked over to the door and opened it ever so slightly to see Shouto standing there with a friendly smile. Katsuki didn’t return the morning cheer. The undercover detective gave him a small wave and peered inside the room curiously.

“Good afternoon,” Shouto said in a quiet voice when he caught sight of the sleeping Izuku. “Sorry to bother you guys. I was nominated by our Paradise Crew to come do a check in since you two missed breakfast and lunch.”

That alerted him.

“We missed breakfast *and* lunch?” Katsuki groggily asked.

He furrowed his brow and leaned out to read Shouto's sleek watch. His eyes widened. It was well into the afternoon. *Fuck*. They really had been asleep all day.

"Mhm. We wanted to make sure you two were okay," Shouto said. He shrugged lightly. "We're all about to go bowling soon. If you want, we can wait on you."

Katsuki sucked in a deep inhale at that proposal. He didn't exactly feel like sharing Izuku's attention today—or any time soon for that matter. There were so many questions that were burning inside of his chest that he was holding back. If he didn't get the chance to have them answered, he feared he might explode from holding them inside. At that moment, Katsuki glanced behind him at the long-lost childhood friend. His green curls were sprayed across the silk pillow as he cuddled in further to the covers.

Katsuki turned back around to Shouto with a reluctant expression and leaned against the door frame.

"I think we'll pass today," Katsuki quietly whispered. His eyes stared down at Shouto's red and white sneakers. "We, uh, had a late night, so I think we're going to take the day to rest and relax for a while. Just the two of us."

"Ah, that's fine," Shouto said with an approving look. He smiled at Katsuki as though he was happy to hear that. "Getting some quality time in?"

Katsuki froze a little. "Um, sure. Quality time. We'll see you all tomorrow at the carnival."

"Sounds good. See you then Taro," Shouto said. He waved goodbye and then walked back down the long hallway with his hands in his pockets.

Katsuki watched him go carefully. Although he knew he should be focused on the assignment, his brain was stuck on Izuku. It felt like all the memories and questions burning inside of him were ropes. Ropes that were restraining him in place, coiling and searing through his skin. He couldn't move on even if he wanted to.

He quietly locked the door and sauntered back over to the bed. He slid under the covers again and carefully studied how Izuku subconsciously scooted closer to him.

Katsuki didn't move as he stared at their matching wedding rings.

☽ ☽ ☽

By the time Izuku woke up, Katsuki had ordered room service for the two of them.

The service worker rolled in several silver platters for them, filling the room with the savory aroma of the food. Katsuki remembered Izuku had mentioned his favorite food was katsudon. Or something like that. The waiter placed the two bowls on the wooden table in the room with a loud clunk.

Izuku was fully awake now. He sat up in bed. His oversized green pajamas swallowed his figure whole as he rubbed his eyes. Moss colored curls were tousled in every direction, making Izuku's bed head somehow the most adorable shit Katsuki had ever seen. Katsuki

watched as Izuku's eyes widened in surprise at the food on the table and then glanced at the clock on the nightstand.

Izuku's eyebrows shot up sky high.

"Shit!" Izuku yelled. He scrambled for his phone, stood up and stared at Katsuki like the world nearly ended. "We overslept, we missed—"

"—I know," Katsuki interrupted. He closed the door behind the kind service worker with a tight smile before locking it. "I already told the group we're going to take the day to ourselves, and I ordered room service."

Izuku stopped his flailing. He stood frozen in the middle of the room clutching his phone with both hands.

Katsuki raised an eyebrow at him when Izuku stared at him for a prolonged period.

After a while Izuku nodded slowly and put his phone back down. He wiped his sweaty palms on the fabric of his pajama pants and looked towards the two bowls of katsudon on the table.

"Oh. Well. That works," Izuku muttered lamely. "Um, thank you."

"Not a problem at all."

Katsuki walked over to the small round table and sat down in one of the wooden chairs. He picked up the candy-colored chopsticks and leaned back in the chair to start eating. When Izuku still didn't move, Katsuki gave a pointed look and gestured towards Izuku's steaming bowl of food.

"Are you just going to stand there or are you going to eat?" Katsuki asked, mildly impatient.

"S-Shouldn't we be working on taking out Moore?"

Katsuki frowned. "I think Moore can wait a day or two. Shouto basically hinted the police raid isn't for another four days. We have time."

Izuku snapped out of his daze before shyly walking over to the table. "Right."

Izuku sat down across from Katsuki, and the awkwardness was tangible. Words were teetering on the edge of Katsuki's tongue, begging him to say something. *Anything*. But he didn't. Silence as searing as a million burning stars waded in their muteness. The two ate, stealing glances at the other.

Katsuki could feel the weight of his age on his skin with how intensely Izuku was staring at him. Green eyes flickered at his features. Like he was trying to make sense of him. He wondered if Izuku was having trouble overlapping his younger self and present self as well. They should talk. But he simply didn't know where to start. He feared if he began simply asking one question, it would snowball into a million.

So instead, he watched Izuku scoff down the katsudon. There was an indescribable wrench in his heart when Izuku finished his food first. Katsuki then glanced down at his bowl and without a word pushed it across the table. The other man froze, stunned.

“You don’t want it?” Izuku questioned carefully.

“You can have it,” Katsuki muttered under his breath. “I’ve never seen you inhale food faster. I’m sure you swallowed some of that chicken fucking whole.”

He grabbed Izuku’s empty bowl to ignore the way his heart twisted and set it aside. Izuku quietly muttered ‘thank you’ before digging into it. There was a distinctive look of bliss on that freckled face, and Katsuki subconsciously made a mental note that Izuku *really* liked katsudon.

As Izuku ate the second bowl of food, Katsuki poured tea for them with his legs crossed. The white porcelain cups were neatly decorated with ink drawings of two tiny birds.

“I…I have a lot of questions,” Izuku suddenly said. He put his chopsticks neatly across the empty bowl and grabbed his cup of tea. “If it’s alright, I would like to ask them. B-But only if you’re comfortable.”

“Same,” Katsuki replied. He sipped his tea without taking his eyes off Izuku. “You can go first.”

“What happened? O-Or where did you go?” Izuku whispered, barely inaudible. “I know you mentioned your mother b-but I…I worried something bad happened to you that day. I thought maybe someone kidnapped you at the carnival because I was late. Or worse.”

Katsuki’s heart hammered in his chest like a pounding drum. He averted his gaze when Izuku made a pained face.

“My mother came and found me that day,” Katsuki admitted. “She said we would come back —but we never did. She feared ever setting foot in Tokyo again for some reason so…we didn’t.”

Izuku nodded slowly. He gave a forced smile. “I-I’m glad you found her again.”

Katsuki didn’t say anything because he was unsure if he really felt the same.

“I came back to Tokyo when I was thirteen,” Katsuki confessed. Izuku’s breathing stopped slightly. “I went to the church, and it was still there. I—I went inside of the nook.”

Izuku’s eyes averted this time. He stared down at the small ripples in the tea.

His fingers strummed along the porcelain cup as if he knew where this was going. Both men waded in the stretch of quiet. Katsuki leaned in with a face twisted in woe as he thought about the note that was left behind. The first question that he wanted to know burned on his tongue as he studied how dejected Izuku’s expression became.

“How long did you wait for me to come back?” Katsuki murmured.

Izuku gave a melancholy half-smile. “Does it matter how long I waited?”

“*Izuku*,” Katsuki hissed. “How long did you wait?”

“…A year.”

The shattering of his own heart was immobilizing.

It crumbled underneath the lifetime worth of guilt that was already stockpiled, but hearing that answer caused the weight to multiply by tenfold. A year. He cursed under his breath and leaned away with his hand covering his mouth in shock. A full fucking year Izuku waited for him to come back—and he never did. He fixated on the thought of young Izuku growing sadder day by day, abandoned in the winter just like he was.

The expression twisted on his face must’ve been of pure remorse because Izuku leaned forward and gently placed his hand in front of him on the wooden table.

“It’s okay, Katsuki. Your mom came back for you, and that’s what we wanted…right?” Izuku gave him an understanding smile. Katsuki didn’t quite feel like he deserved such a thing. “That’s the whole reason we stayed so close to that plaza so she could come back for you. T-The whole running away thing was something we came up with solely because we thought she died, right? But she hadn’t and she came back. I’m glad that you were reunited with her.”

Katsuki shook his head.

No matter how kind Izuku’s words were, they couldn’t absolve the poisonous guilt that was coursing through his veins. They weren’t solely running away because his mom had abandoned him—there were other things: like Izuku’s bruises. He thought about the dust covered note and what it said on it.

Sharp, red eyes cut towards Izuku.

“What about that older brother of yours?” Katsuki asked. His voice was wary. “Did he ever stop hurting you?”

Izuku tensed. He curled his fingers on the tabletop and his face hardened slightly.

“We don’t have to talk about that, Katsuki.”

“Yes. Yes, we fucking *do*, Izuku,” Katsuki insisted anxiously. “I fucking left you there knowing someone was *hurting* you. You came all the time with goddamn bruises and a full-on broken bone once. And your fucking *eye* was cut up. You have no fucking clue how the guilt of that ate away at me for years. I-I wanted to take you with me and my mom, so he couldn’t hurt you anymore but she—*we*—we didn’t fucking come back.”

“You couldn’t control that. You were a kid—”

“—Did he stop or not? I need to know, Izuku.”

Izuku retracted his hand and leaned back in the creaky wooden chair. Katsuki's heart thumped with every beat of silence. He couldn't help but notice the body language shift. Izuku curled into himself slightly, hung his head away and clenched his jaw.

"No. He didn't."

Katsuki became nauseous as he imagined all the years filled with bloodied eyes, broken bones, and possibly much worse injuries. His stomach quaked with nausea as he studied Izuku's defensive, closed off body language.

"I'm…I'm so fucking sorry, Izuku."

His throat dried up, like someone had snatched all the possible words from his mouth and scraped his esophagus along the way. He didn't know what else to say but how he felt: sorry. Slightly pathetic. Remorseful. His well rooted self-hatred sunk its clutches further into him to the point his chest heaved.

"You have nothing to be sorry for. It's not your fault," Izuku repeated.

"It is. I left you there. You were being hurt, and I left you."

"But you were a *kid*," Izuku emphasized. "You were a kid who was left abandoned in a giant city waiting for an irresponsible adult to come back. Then she did. You did what any child would've done in that moment if they were reunited with a parent who loved them. S-Some things in life aren't controllable for us all the time. This was one of those things."

With that explanation, a bridge between young Izuku and older Izuku began to form.

Katsuki grasped at the small bud of an explanation. This had to be how Izuku ended up as a hitman. He must've tried to get out of an abusive household—right? Was that the missing middle?

"Do you still see your brother?" Katsuki asked after a while.

"Um. Yes. Our living arrangements are complicated," Izuku confessed, slightly skittish. He took a small sip of his tea unhurriedly. His eyes grew distant and unfocused. "But—I try my best to put distance between us for obvious purposes."

"Is that the reason you took this type of job? To try to get away from him?"

Izuku frowned deeply and placed his teacup down. "No."

"But you said you do this job to survive."

"I do." Izuku's voice tightened with vindication. "But he has nothing to do with that." Izuku seemed unsure of his words in the last sentence.

"Then *why*?" Katsuki exasperated. "Why would someone as kind—or *was* as kind as you—go into this type of shit? *Willingly*?"

Izuku seemed pained by that. Pained enough that he didn't answer.

His green eyes grew darker, clearly wounded. He studied Katsuki carefully from across the wooden table. Katsuki stared right back at him, struggling to piece together what had transpired.

As he tried, his head was beginning to hurt more. If not to get away from that shit faced abusive brother, then why the hell would Izuku do this type of gig? Katsuki's brain struggled once more to join the past Izuku and the present.

"I don't fucking get it," Katsuki continued. "You were so kind, gentle, and well off. You weren't meant for this type of life. I always thought you would go on to be a teacher or go into a profession that helped people. Not *kill* them."

"I'm sorry I didn't turn out how you wanted me to," Izuku muttered sarcastically. He sneered deeply at Katsuki and there was soreness evident in his words. "I know you think I'm *fucked up* but please understand not everything in the world is a simple choice. My apologies for tainting that memory for you."

Shit.

Katsuki licked his dry lips and shook his head. "I didn't mean it like that."

"You did," Izuku bitterly cut off. "It's fine. I know I'm fucked up, alright? I get it. I always had a feeling you would be disappointed about what I am if we ever met again." The green in Izuku's eyes drowned in a deep cynicism as he hung his head. "I know I'm not normal."

"I'm sorry," Katsuki said quietly. "You're not any more messed up than I am. I actually always assumed you would be disappointed in me if you saw what I grew up to be."

"I'm not, if that helps." Izuku gave him a sad smile. "I'm really just happy that you grew up. I assumed you were dead. Y-You hadn't taken any of your stuff with you, and I struggled to understand why you didn't want to bring your favorite toy with you if you had left. Knowing you're alive is…all I could really ask for."

Katsuki stared at Izuku like a puzzle as his heart clenched.

There was a sense of relief upon those words reaching his ears. He didn't know how to respond as his self-hatred clutched on to him tighter, having a mild reaction to the fact Izuku wasn't disappointed in what he had become.

"I shouldn't have snapped on you like that yesterday," Katsuki apologized, ignoring the way his heart skipped. "I was out of line."

"No, it's alright. You should've," Izuku rebutted. "I hadn't said anything. As far as you knew I was simply some guy who you've been fighting with for years using a nickname that was dear to you. It made you uncomfortable. And if it still makes you uncomfortable, I won't ever use it again."

Katsuki opened his mouth, stunned by the suggestion.

His immediate reflex was to tell Izuku ‘no, it’s fine,’ but then he realized, should he? Should he tell Izuku to call him fucking ‘Kacchan’ like they were seven years old again? Would that be weird? Fuck. It probably would be. They had been at each other’s throats for so long that not even their current ‘truce’ would bridge the gap this fast. This was such an unusual situation to navigate, and his pulsing migraine didn’t help a damn thing.

Izuku stared at him for a moment, as if wanting him to correct it. But they stayed in a quiet stalemate.

“I don’t care if you use it or not,” Katsuki settled for. He turned his eyes away to the rosy curtains and took a large gulp of his tea. “That’s your choice I guess.”

There was another drop of muteness as Izuku kept his eyes trained on the carpet.

It didn’t go unnoticed to Katsuki how Izuku reframed from answering his question about how he became a hitman. However, the idea of Izuku running away from him again made Katsuki step back from pressing on about that. There was an antsy aura clouded around Izuku, and he clearly was teetering on the edge of a flight or fight response. Katsuki really didn’t want him to try to flee away once more.

Especially not when they finally unearthed such an important connection.

Katsuki leaned forward on the table. He stared at the way Izuku’s curls coiled in some places and were wavy in others. He took in the details of freckles and noticed how a couple of them formed a small diamond on both of his cheeks. Katsuki couldn’t quite put together the beginning and end of Izuku just yet, but he decided maybe it was alright for now.

Izuku turned to him again, but this time he was equipped with a soft expression. He clearly buried whatever emotion that had been triggered before.

“If you don’t mind, I would love to hear about your life after the carnival day,” Izuku whispered. He gave a smile worth a thousand suns.

“Sure, on one condition,” Katsuki wagered.

“What would that be?”

“You buy the next round of food,” Katsuki said. The corners of his lips tugged upwards ever so slightly. Not a full smile, but just enough that it made Izuku smile more at him in return. “I’m still starving.”

“I think that’s manageable,” Izuku laughed slightly. He pushed a stray curl behind his ear.

Izuku went to order more food, picking up the fuchsia phone on the nightstand.

Katsuki studied the back of him. He observed the way Izuku had a bias for leaning on his left foot, putting his body weight there while placing his hand on his right hip. There was a slight sway in his body as he stayed idle and ordered Katsuki’s favorite dish.

Izuku turned and smiled at him. He gave a thumbs up like they were all set to go.

To Katsuki, it all functioned like an atypical dream. His thoughts were floating in and out of self-hate, remorse, relief, but above all all-consuming curiosity. His inquisitiveness tugged on his heart and mind until they were working overtime to tie the two ends of Izuku into one cohesive stream. Yet, without the middle explanation it was fruitless, and it appeared like Izuku wasn't inclined to give it to him.

Katsuki tried to let it go, but he couldn't.

He curled his fists in his lap when his heart began to beat quickly in a tempo he hated. He knew then that this might be his damnation as Izuku sat across from him again with those pretty green eyes.

☽ ☽ ☽

They spent the rest of the evening discussing what had happened between then and now. Or at least bits of it. Izuku still didn't elaborate fully on his own past. He deflected like an expert and clung to whichever sentence gave him enough wiggle room out of talking about himself. Because of this, Katsuki kept most of his past private too.

He only lightly touched on certain topics such as his mother's drug addiction and the events that led up to her death. Plus, a rundown of the basics: how he took on the offer of being a hitman to alleviate the weight of her gambling debt.

By the time he mentioned that the sky was bleeding from happy, bright blue to dark, moody purple.

They were out on the balcony, leaning against the metal railing. Katsuki viewed from above as the other vacation goers bustled about. However, Izuku was watching him. The wind blew through his curly hair and a pensive expression was pinned on his doll-like face. It wasn't a look of pity like Katsuki originally thought Izuku would give him. Or had given him. Instead, it was a look of vague understanding, and strange kinship.

"You mentioned she passed away," Izuku started when Katsuki finished talking about the money issues. "I'm sorry you had to experience that. If you don't mind me asking, how did it happen?"

"It's my fault really," Katsuki murmured. "I had botched this assignment for some shady gangsters when I found out we were lied to about what the assignment was. I refused to give back their payment because I needed to pay my rent and my mothers. So, I mouthed off like the fucking brat I was that young and took shit into my own hands. They said I would regret crossing them, but I guess I didn't really *think* about exactly what they meant."

Katsuki inwardly winced as those memories came rushing forward.

He could still smell the stench of rotten flesh and feel the burn in his chest. A bloodied corpse sitting in the middle of the room with a single bullet hole in the skull.

"My supervisor warned me I needed to be careful," Katsuki continued with a distant expression. "He even told me I should personally make amends and give back the money. But

I was so overconfident that no one would get the jump on me that I didn't stop to consider they would go after my family. They killed her to get back at me because I made shit personal. There was nothing my agency could do because they couldn't directly tie it back to him. But I fucking *know* it was him—the timing of it lined up precisely and when I saw that smug faced fucker again, he took a jab at me about it."

"What was his name?" Izuku asked. He looked enraged on Katsuki's behalf.

"Akaguro Chizome," Katsuki spat the name like it tasted rancid. "Ring any bells?"

"No," Izuku said honestly. "I've never heard of him."

"He's a notorious drug lord in the underground Osaka scene. Sometimes deals in black-market weapons trade. He has his sleazy hands in all corners of that city."

Katsuki could perfectly remember the way the vile man leered at him, sitting in his false throne of a chair in his headquarters. Even now, the deep chuckle of Akaguro still vibrates through Katsuki. The gangster warned him that he would only have himself to blame for the blood that was going to be shed. Katsuki was too young to consider that the blood wouldn't be his. Now, it was all he could think about.

"I hope you're planning on getting even with him," Izuku said sourly. Katsuki could almost feel the protective vengefulness radiating off of him. "He shouldn't be allowed to get away with that if he was the person who lied about what the assignment was."

"I'm going to get my revenge when I have the time," Katsuki guaranteed. The wind blew again, its cool touch soothed some of Katsuki's anger. "Right now, I'm focused on the assignments I'm given. Ironic in a way. I took this job to keep us both alive, but it wound up causing her death. When the moment comes, I'll go back for that bastard and all his goons."

"Good."

Izuku nodded at him in approval. For the first time, Katsuki felt a bit understood.

Usually, when he spoke of his mother's murder, people expected him to take the high road. All that 'live and let live' bullshit. Hell, even Aizawa told him executing revenge on Akaguro Chizome would be trouble. His supervisor had immediately cut all ties with the gangster after he found out they lied about the assignment's details. But Aizawa still advised Katsuki the best he could do was mourn *quietly*.

Izuku was the first person who hinted that he should lean into his malevolent side. The Scarlet Eyed Killer part of him.

It was attention-grabbing to hear Izuku agree that there was blood weight that needed to be evened. Maybe it was because Izuku knew how much his mother meant to him as a child. Or maybe it was simply because Izuku was possibly as messed up as he was.

Whichever the case, Izuku became a little more interesting.

The evening went on to more casual conversation. Such as, where did they go to school. He told Izuku he dropped out after high school, feeling like he no longer needed the righteous pathway of higher education. Izuku told him he had remained homeschooled for all of his life.

“Homeschooled?” Katsuki questioned. He was a little surprised. “Why?”

Izuku shrugged. “It's the way my family operates.”

They found themselves wandering back inside once the sun set. Katsuki turned on the pink lamp, letting the rose-colored hue spill all over the room. Eventually they sat on the ground, leaning their backs against the bed. The pair ordered more food as they caught up, putting on the TV in the background.

At one point, Katsuki took Izuku’s violin out of its case and inspected it. He held back showing too much amazement. It really was the same damn violin.

“Did that looney old man give this to you?” Katsuki asked.

He turned over the frail instrument in his hands, examining all the nicks and scrapes. He never thought he’d see it again, yet here it was: withstanding the test of time somehow like he and Izuku had.

“He did,” Izuku replied with a sad smile. “Said it was mine to keep for as long as I liked.”

“What happened to him?”

“I’m not entirely sure.” Izuku made a contemplative face. “That year I waited for you to come back, he offered to teach me violin to keep me occupied. He showed me just about everything he knew. But then one day while I was in school, construction on the plaza happened. Police forcefully moved all the homeless people in the area somewhere. I came back, and everyone had vanished. There was no trace of him left.”

Katsuki imagined it: young Izuku eagerly walking to the plaza for his impromptu violin lessons. Then standing there shocked by the emptiness. Laughter of people was replaced with cold construction and yellow tape, telling him he couldn’t walk into the place he had grown attached to for two years. Katsuki didn’t even want to fathom what type of hollowness possibly set into Izuku that day.

“I’m sorry,” Katsuki whispered once more. “I’m so damn sorry.”

“You’re saying sorry a lot.” Izuku gave Katsuki a soothing smile. “No more saying sorry, okay? We can be sorry about what happened all we want but we’re here now.”

“Alright,” Katsuki chuckled. He scratched behind his head. “But I do have one more question.”

He looked into Izuku’s eyes and for the first time, he wasn’t fully thrown off guard by all of this. Green eyes finally were familiar in a way that wasn’t eerie or ghostly. He could see the

alignment of young Izuku and older Izuku overlap a bit. But only a bit. A lump swelled in his throat as he struggled to ask that mystery that was digging into him for years.

“Why were you late that day to the carnival, Izuku?”

The words suspended in air as Izuku visibly stiffened.

Then slowly, Izuku relaxed. His shoulders sagging slightly underneath some invisible weight. He gave a desolate expression. That was all the answer Katsuki needed. Izuku didn’t have to elaborate on what happened when his eyes gazed at him like that.

“I think you know why.”

And Katsuki did. Izuku’s crestfallen features filled in the gaps.

It was his older fucking brother.

More rage ticked inside of Katsuki. It ticked and ticked like a bomb ready to explode in all directions. He realized at that moment this rage was old. It had sat inside of him disregarded for years. It was a fury he saved solely for Izuku’s older brother. It birthed at the sight of that broken arm and all the bruises. However, he had buried this rage when they were separated and never revisited it again because he hadn’t *needed* to.

But now, knowing that the mere reason life could have been different was because of that fucking brother filled his chest with that old anger.

Katsuki had to take a large inhale to expand his ribcage to make room for it. He started to open his mouth and say sorry once more—but Izuku stopped him. The other man leaned over, touched his hand, and squeezed it for the first time today.

The gentle touch was like cool water for Katsuki’s fire. He realized he nearly missed it after being absent all day. It felt different now, like a missing piece of a jigsaw being put in place after searching for it all over the couch. It was rewarding, gratifying, and comforting in a way Katsuki couldn’t exactly explain. His heart skipped and gradually, he simmered down.

He squeezed Izuku’s hand back in hopes of a silent communication.

He wished he could say sorry one last time.

☽ ☽ ☽

The evening blended with them trying to find more normalcy. Izuku made him promise not to say sorry for things out of his control, and Izuku promised the same.

The separation not being his fault was a truth that Katsuki wasn’t aware he needed to be told. But upon hearing that, a tiny bit of his self-hatred melted. It eased up ever so slightly, allowing him to breathe a bit more. But despite this, there was still a side of him that wanted to do better by Izuku as repentance for leaving him. Especially because he left him with someone who hurt him enough that he was still skittish at the mention of it.

While Izuku had casually suggested that Katsuki should kill Chizome, Katsuki wasn't quite sure he could suggest the same violence to Izuku. Part of Katsuki wanted to. He had never even met this older brother, but he wanted him to feel some level of agony for beating a child.

However, Katsuki let it go. At the end of the day, family affairs were complex and Katsuki was merely a stranger. A long-lost childhood friend, but a stranger, nonetheless.

Now they sat comfortably on the heart shaped bed, watching old superhero movies that they had binged on in their years apart. It mended a part of Katsuki because he always wondered if Izuku enjoyed these films as well. They talked about their favorite characters, favorite scenes, and even what superpowers they would have if they lived in such a world. It was astonishing how they pretty much agreed on everything.

Well, almost everything.

"You're *kidding* me," Izuku gasped loudly. He threw a small piece of popcorn at Katsuki with a scandalized glare. "You thought Heroes Rising was better than the first All Might movie?!"

Katsuki easily caught the air-born piece of popcorn in his mouth. He chewed it with an arrogant grin as the TV played one superhero movie in the background.

"Yeah, I fucking did because I have *taste*," Katsuki teased. He leaned on the backboard of the bed with his arms crossed. "Something you clearly fucking lack if you thought the first movie was better than the second."

"But it was so good! And not to mention groundbreaking! The graphics of the quirks in the CGI helped push cinematography into the next level. Are you going to ignore that?!"

"Yup," Katsuki said. He popped more popcorn in his mouth and flexed his brows. "You can't convince me otherwise."

"I'm happy we didn't see the movies together now," Izuku grumbled with no bite. "I would've left you at the theater for uttering that nonsense."

"You were too much of a cry baby back then to have left me," Katsuki shot back. "You probably would've just sat pissed off outside of the theater with your arms crossed. Probably would've had the same stupid little pout you have on now."

Izuku gasped. "I do *not* pout—"

Katsuki shot Izuku an unimpressed stare that read 'really?' and Izuku stumbled over his words. Quickly, Izuku fixed his face. He sucked in his lips and flared his nose to appear more serious. Katsuki snickered loudly because it was clear Izuku was reframing from pouting as he did his best to frown instead.

"Like I said. I don't pout," Izuku corrected, looking ridiculous.

Katsuki shook his head and ate more popcorn. "Keep telling yourself that. You pout every time you don't get your way like a fucking brat. Even when I was running into you on assignments, you fucking pouted whenever you saw me."

Izuku's mouth dropped, and he looked as though he was about to protest again. However, his words were cut short by another knock on their door.

Both men froze and stared at each other. Something about the moment was slightly broken, like cold water being splashed on them. The knocking continued, reminding them that they were very much still in this hotel for more reasons than to catch up with each other.

Katsuki muttered under his breath that he'd get the door as he moved the bowl of popcorn off his lap. The TV continued making loud noises as the movie got to an action-packed scene.

Katsuki opened the door carefully, still feeling a bit overly protective of Izuku's time. Standing there with a bright smile was Jirou. Her dark purple hair was pinned up and the gauges in her ears looked a little bigger to Katsuki today. She gave him a big smile and held up a giant brown box.

"Hey, Taro!" Jirou said cheerily. "Here's those comics I was talking about the other day."

Katsuki blinked. "Oh, damn. Thanks, I forgot about these," he said as she pushed the box in his arms. It was heavy. Really fucking heavy actually. He grunted slightly as he held them up.

"Me too," Jirou laughed. "But I heard you two were getting some quality time in and figured I come drop them off now."

"Well thanks."

"Not a problem. Enjoy your night!"

She gave him a two-finger salute before waving goodbye. A small suggestive wink was given and Katsuki resisted blushing. He turned back around with the box in his hand, kicking the door closed.

Izuku's doe eyes widened at the sight.

"Oh! The All Might comics!" Izuku exclaimed happily. He sat up, alert and gave a big grin. He clasped his hands together like he was containing his excitement. "Wait! Let's pause the movie. Do you want to go through the comics and see if any of them are familiar?"

A tiny piece of Katsuki eagerly agreed.

"Sure," Katsuki said coolly. He shrugged like it wasn't a big deal, but that tiny quiet voice was gleeful. "I think that sounds like a decent plan."

☽ ☽ ☽

It ended up being a wonderful idea. Katsuki had no clue that reading and pawing through all these old comics would bring him this much joy. He was secretly ecstatic to be viewing them, beyond ecstatic honestly.

But it was odd in a way.

He had buried all this, glittering child-like wonder when he was young. No comics. No fun. No toys or even fathoming dwelling in selfish enjoyment. He pushed all those thoughts to the bottom of his mind and only indulged in the All-Might movies as a guilty pass time. But only on the days his life was extra blue. There was something about comics that he never could touch again when he was a teen. Before, he was unsure why that was. But now, staring at Izuku's happy freckled face gave him the exact answer why he never had the strength to revisit his love for comics.

The evening quickly faded into the late night. Every second was spent indulging themselves in the fictional heroes they admired in their past.

Katsuki hadn't even realized he spent the full day with Izuku and only Izuku. It was like someone had repaired up a piece of him, as if he was a forgotten quilt with large holes scattered throughout. Simply looking at these drawings patched tiny squares of missing childhood over his gaps. He almost felt whole, and everything seemed relatively alright.

However, despite all this, the image of younger Izuku and older Izuku still struggled to blend.

He tried to push the pieces together and make them fit.

Currently, they were now reading through all the comics Katsuki had neglected.

Izuku filled him in on all the fantasy world happenings he had missed with enthusiasm he'd never seen someone have. Well, he had only seen younger Izuku have this type of enthusiasm —and here was Izuku: displaying the same type of zealousness.

Izuku was shaping up to still be…*Izuku*.

Katsuki furrowed his brow.

They sat on the bed closely, shoulder to shoulder. Neither one of them mentioned the unneeded proximity as they started rummaging through the box of comics. Izuku was babbling about something that Katsuki didn't register all the way. The memories of all the days in the nook reading together were overshadowing the present. He could still recall the smell of burnt wax on the shelves when Izuku read to him for hours.

Scarlet eyes discreetly surveyed the man next to him, who was curling into him.

If Izuku moved in just a smidge more, he could easily plant his head on Katsuki's shoulder. Katsuki blushed lightly and wondered if Izuku was aware he was doing this, or if it was a strange instinct. The gleeful man was thumbing through the flimsy comic pages, green eyes sparkling with innocent marvel.

Izuku turned his head to him, beaming brightly.

"Do you remember this one?" Izuku asked. He held up a comic that read 'issue #323' in bold, white font on the top. "This was the one you asked me to read to you a lot. I'm pretty sure I read this to you about a hundred times."

Katsuki chuckled, finding a comforting nostalgia in the moment. He reached for the comic, and even though it was lighter than feathers, it contained all the heavy weight of the past.

“Yeah, I fucking remember.” Katsuki grinned in a way he hadn’t for a long time. “I’m surprised you didn’t get sick of it. You must’ve really liked it too.”

“Oh, I actually hated this issue,” Izuku said with a dry laugh. “It’s probably my least favorite honestly.”

Katsuki frowned. “What? But you read it so much.”

“Yeah, I know. But I only liked reading to you,” Izuku confessed. He smiled nervously and twisted the ring around his finger. “Back then, you could’ve asked me to read it every day for hours. I probably would have done it just to see you smile.”

Katsuki didn’t know what to say to that.

His eyes flickered to the way Izuku was twisting his metal ring. In Katsuki’s mind, it shifted to a fabric ring. He quietly thumbed the thin paper of the comic under his fingertips. He struggled to tear his eyes away from Izuku, who was giving him a gaze that was purely sentimental.

Izuku was still sweet.

Those words were exactly something he would have anticipated young Izuku saying. But now this older version of him was saying it, and it seemed nearly as authentic. A tiny voice in the back of Katsuki’s head, that sounded awfully like a young version of himself, wondered if Izuku still felt the same about reading to him. It was silly, but he wondered if those feelings of deep care were still present. Or had that dried up like a forgotten river?

Izuku cleared his throat and reached for the comic.

“If you want, I can read it to you again. J-Just for old times’ sake,” Izuku offered calmly. He was clearly embarrassed, but hopefulness pushed through. “I wouldn’t mind.”

Katsuki tensed at the thought. He didn’t know why—but hearing that gave him relief. That tiny voice in the back of his head was quietly cheering, and he could feel his inner child clap happily. He pawed at his black shorts, hesitant.

Despite the younger side of his spirit feeling ecstatic for the offer, this was intimate.

“How about I read to you this time?” Katsuki suggested. All the alarms were going off in his head the second he said that. He pushed past the warnings his brain was giving him as his heart sped up. “You know, I’m not that illiterate seven-year-old anymore. Let me return the favor for a bit.”

“O-Oh, okay,” Izuku stuttered. His expression was both proud and intrigued. “That would be cool! Sorry, I think I forgot that you probably could read the comics on your own.”

“It’s alright, nerd,” Katsuki said. He grabbed the comic back from Izuku with a small smirk and flipped open to the first page. There was light dust on the pages as he rubbed it off. “Let me show you my new and improved reading skills.”

Izuku laughed and scooted in every so slightly. He nervously fiddled with his fingers and leaned into him to see the text on the page. Now they were firmly pressed together, side by side. It was entirely not needed, especially if Katsuki was reading out loud—but neither of them said a word about it.

“Do…Do you want to read how we used to?” Izuku asked suddenly.

“Hah? What do you mean?”

“We used to read under the covers most of the time. With a flashlight and we would get lost in like a little makeshift world.”

Katsuki’s eyebrows shot up a bit. “We’re a bit old for that don’t you think?”

“It would be kind of fun!” Izuku insisted with a delightful smile. The edges of his eyes happily curled up with his grin. “I haven’t done that in so long. It’ll be just like when we were kids.”

Katsuki’s eyes glazed over Izuku’s body before meeting his gaze. Izuku shifted lightly on the mattress, a tiny hint of blush peeked from underneath his freckles.

“We’re far from being kids anymore, Izuku.”

“I know,” Izuku said. His cheeks pinkened a tinge. “I-I think that it would be fun. I—I don’t know.” He averted his eyes to the silk bed sheets and scratched behind his head. “I’m having fun catching up with you and I-I thought with the movies and going through the comics we could keep doing things that we used to.”

Izuku looked nearly like a kicked puppy, and he pouted. The little fucker *pouted*.

Katsuki loathed the way he instantly folded.

“Fine,” Katsuki grumbled.

Izuku immediately perked up, and Katsuki told himself that this was simply indulgent.

The way pretty, green eyes lit up made Katsuki’s younger side feel satisfied.

They began to clear the bed of the comics, placing them neatly back in the brown box. They picked out a couple to read and there was a fluttering excitement growing inside of Katsuki. He had no clue he could really feel like this, it was new. Or was it old? It was a mixture of both when he examined it.

They shuffled covers together, both snickering at the way it was a bit ridiculous. They took the front end of the blanket and secured it on the top of the high headboard. The red silk blanket fell gracefully. It created a neat, enveloped tent for them on the bed as they secured

the other end of the blankets to the opposite edge of the bed. The space underneath the makeshift tent-covers was snug in a familiar way.

It was almost like the nook they sat up. But Katsuki didn't say that out loud when he looked at their rings again.

They both climbed inside and leaned against the headboard. Katsuki placed down the selected comics with a smirk and Izuku had a happy smile on his face. His grin was so wide Katsuki was sure his cheeks must've hurt.

Izuku lit the flashlight on the back of his phone under the dark covers. He placed the device between their bodies, so the white light spilled upwards. The red silk reflected against the bright luminescence, tinging them both in a deep hue of red. Katsuki opened up to the first page and Izuku scooted in. Their shoulders flushed together and soon they both were lost in the moment.

Katsuki read out loud. Izuku hung on his every word like he was reading what the secret to life was. They laughed in some parts and gasped together in others. Time didn't feel real underneath the blanket to Katsuki. The concept of the outside world ceased.

There was no Moore. No Aizawa. No assignment. Only this small makeshift tent that reminded him of the single year that was most important to him. It felt like they were transported to a secret place only meant for the two of them to make up for lost time.

As he was reading, Katsuki could feel Izuku shift closer to him on the mattress. Izuku carefully leaned down his head to his shoulder—exactly like he used to do.

Katsuki had turned to him, and they made eye contact briefly.

He was going to say something but stopped himself when the words jammed in his throat. The heat under his collar tickled a bit as he turned his eyes back to the words on the page. Then, as he continued they shifted a bit. He didn't notice exactly when their feet tangled, but they had. The soft skin against his was nice in a way that Katsuki cherished secretly.

After however many hours had passed, they slid down to a more comfortable position. Izuku had his head against one of the soft pillows. He was lying on his side, body turned inward to Katsuki with a tiny smile.

Katsuki was turned inward as well on his side. He propped his head up with one hand as he held up the comic for both him and Izuku to see. Neither made a move to untangle their legs as he read. With every laugh and moment of suspense in the comic, Katsuki could feel Izuku move. And he moved closer each time until they were nearly face to face.

"And that's the end," Katsuki said as he flipped to the last page. "To be continued."

He looked towards Izuku, only now fully aware of how close they'd gotten.

He could see all the shades of Izuku's freckles. The dark ones and the light shaded mocha ones. He could see the different patterns that they formed as Izuku laid his head against the

red pillow. His messy curls were sprawled everywhere, and his deep green eyes were staring right back at Katsuki with an unreadable emotion.

“That was actually really nice,” Izuku confessed after a while. He smiled delicately at Katsuki, and their feet knocked a bit. “Did you enjoy reading to me for once?”

“Surprisingly, yeah I did,” Katsuki agreed with a chuckle. He couldn’t stop himself from smirking. “Never thought I would be reading these goddamn comics again, but it was nice to catch up on them. How did you like my reading skills? Better than when I was seven I hope.”

“Of course. You did great,” Izuku said. “I could get used to you reading to me.”

“Oh, really now?”

“Mhm. You have a good voice for it. Maybe you should make audio-books.”

Katsuki snorted sarcastically and rolled his eyes. “I curse too much. Not a damn soul would buy any audio books narrated by me.”

Izuku shrugged. “I like when you curse. So, I’d buy them.”

Another sweet comment.

Katsuki’s smirk shifted into a subtle, tender smile without his knowledge.

He was beginning to align young Izuku to older Izuku a bit. At the core, it seemed they were both still the same sweet person. Katsuki studied Izuku a bit longer in that moment of silence. Izuku seemed to do the same. Saccharine, doe eyes stared into his endlessly like Izuku was studying the galaxies and nebulas above them. Neither said anything as they lingered in the lost years.

An usual sensation flooded Katsuki’s chest as he gazed at Izuku. It twisted, flipped, and *pulled*. He couldn’t get enough of looking at the missing piece of his childhood in front of him. It was almost ridiculous. Katsuki wondered when the shock would wear off—or if it might ever.

As Katsuki was considering the other man’s features, he didn’t notice he had drawn closer. The sound of Izuku’s breath hitching was the only indicator that he had moved.

There was a shift in the air.

The comic was placed down and the heat under the covers had spiked. He knew they should move. Or talk. Or, hell, even check the time. But they didn’t. They were stuck in each other’s gravities.

Izuku lifted a hand, hesitant.

Katsuki didn’t dare move, only continued to watch him.

The warm hand cupped his cheek and touched him like he was made of glass. Izuku's soft fingers caressed his cheek bone. The entire time, Izuku studied him like he was a work of art. Like he was some valuable painting that had been missing for centuries and finally returned to where it belonged. Then, Izuku stared at his mouth for a while. As though there were words there to be read. Katsuki stared right back at Izuku's, examining the soft curvature of his cupid's bow.

The intimacy of their positions reminded Katsuki of their make-believe marriage vows. He remembered how the nook had been dimly lit, just like the makeshift tent was now. He remembered how they quickly locked lips, both too young to really understand they stole each other's first kiss.

He wondered if Izuku was thinking the same thing as the man stared at his mouth.

An unknown emotion gripped Katsuki by the heart. It was heavy, warm, and kicked up a hurricane of backlogged memories. Katsuki wasn't sure what emotion it was, but it slowed the moment down and made him savor it.

"W-We should get ready for bed," Izuku whispered. "It's getting late."

Katsuki's half-lidded gaze intensely burned through Izuku, and he could sense the nerves rattling off of the other man. Izuku was shaking slightly, the legs entangled with his were jittering faintly.

"…Okay," Katsuki whispered. His raspy voice grazed the bottom of his vocal cords as they stared into each other.

Izuku broke apart from the moment, clearly in a transfixed daze. His pupils were dilated until there was nothing but a slim ring of viridian on the outside. He swallowed dryly and rubbed the back of his nape as he sat up.

Izuku muttered an apology as he climbed out of the makeshift tent.

Katsuki flopped on his back, carefully listening to Izuku's shuffling. He waited until he heard the shutting of the bathroom door to exhale. He laid there, lost in thought for a while. The sound of the shower ran in the background but all that was running through Katsuki's head was Izuku.

He privately ghosted his fingers over his lips, trying to identify the new emotion that slithered in.

☽ ☽ ☽

When the next day came, they felt different.

The air was heavier. The way Izuku looked at him was softer but more comfortable.

It was the total opposite of where they were the day before. Stale, and dancing around the other one. Katsuki wished he had a larger vocabulary to describe the new atmosphere that developed. It was warm like close skin on skin contact, yet icy as distant friends who hadn't

spoken in years all at once. There were a multitude of unsaid questions rattling between them that neither reached out to touch. Both were too afraid to break the fragile atmosphere.

They skipped breakfast and lunch again, and no one came up to check up on them as they ordered room service. Katsuki stared at the pink colored door all morning, realizing once they stepped outside everything would resume.

The world around them would materialize again. Moore and Koizumi. Shouto and Inasa. Suddenly, Katsuki remembered the heavy armory that was neatly tucked away in a secret compartment in his suitcase. He could perfectly envision Moore's deceptively charming smile awaiting them. He could even see that fucking bastard adjust the golden dove pin on his white suit.

But more importantly, that police raid was happening three days from now.

There was an unspoken pressure of time against his shoulder blades as he and Izuku quietly stayed tucked away in the room.

When night fell arrived, the expected knocking on their door came with it.

"Bakugous!" Mina's loud singsong voice cut through the air. "Wakey wakey, love birds! It's time for the carnival!"

Katsuki was currently sitting on the edge of the bed, fastening his black leather watch. He sighed inwardly, utterly not inclined for any of this. There was a prickle on his skin that mimicked invisible barbed wire, sinking and piercing into him from all angles. It was beginning to feel awfully a lot like that shit the old man would ramble on about. Fate. Stars. All that crap.

"We'll be out in a minute," Katsuki yelled. "Hiroji is still getting dressed like a fucking slow poke."

"Sorry!" Izuku called from inside the bathroom. "I-I'm just fixing my hair."

Katsuki donned his normal, short sleeved black button down. He didn't think there was a need to get spiffed up. His pants were regular ink-black jeans with rips, and he wore black combat boots. Katsuki accessorized himself with his black fang earrings and his silver chain around his neck.

Izuku seemed nervous, however. The nerd picked up his normal pink clothes and then nearly had a panic attack. His face painted as rosy as his wardrobe before he quickly clutched his whole suitcase and ran into the bathroom. Now they were running fucking late and he could practically *feel* Shouto on the other side of the door tapping his foot.

"C'mon, you're holding up everyone," Katsuki said impatiently. "That bird's nest of yours wasn't combed all day yesterday. You're not going to make it look nice now."

"Fine, fine. I'm coming," Izuku grumbled.

The door cracked open, and Katsuki exhaled in relief. *Finally*. He stood up, grabbed his phone and turned instinctually towards Izuku. He braced himself for the usual flood of pink in every shade imaginable but froze when the sight in front of him wasn't that.

Stunning. That was the first word to come to mind.

Izuku was wearing a white blouse that had a soft, watercolor pattern of baby pink camellias. The flowers spilled across the flowy fabric like someone had hand painted them on to match Izuku's beauty. It complemented his dark denim jeans and black flats. But what caught Katsuki's eye the most was the way Izuku's hair fell, neatly combed with a product that emphasized the curls of his hair. They looked soft and framed his heart shaped face in a sophisticated manner. He looked pretty, doll-like even. A darling, doe eyed doll face.

Izuku shifted on his feet slightly and Katsuki became hyper aware he was gawking. He could hear his inner voice tell him to move or fucking speak. But it was impossible to peel his eyes away from the striking man in front of him. He could hear their group outside chatting indistinctly and feel himself dryly swallow.

"This is the part where you tell me I look hideous," Izuku said with a light hint of sarcasm. He gave a nervous smile and fidgeted in place. He twirled the ring on his finger while looking at Katsuki up and down.

"Yeah," Katsuki whispered, still dazed. "I suppose it is." There was a trickle of silence as they regarded each other. "This is also the part where you tell me to stop staring."

Izuku nodded distantly and echoed his words. "I suppose it is."

Izuku stepped forward and nervously pushed a stray curl behind his ear. He grabbed for his phone, wallet and rose-tinted heart-shaped glasses. He placed the glasses on top of his curls perfectly. When he turned around he tilted his head shyly, smiling at Katsuki.

For the first time, Katsuki noted that there were at least three shades of green swimming inside of Izuku's eyes. He cleared his throat when he could sense himself gawking far too long and held out a hand for Izuku to take.

When Izuku's fingers intertwined with his, that unnamed emotion sparked all over him.

☽ ☽ ☽

The group walked together into the downtown region of Nago. The summer breeze was gentle and carried all their laughs into the dark night as he held Izuku's hand in his. He knew it was for show but something about it was obviously different now.

Little, tiny caresses were tracing his skin as they walked.

The atmosphere was enjoyable enough that Katsuki nearly forgot why he was in Okinawa. The shade from the palm trees didn't feel ominous. It was relaxing and cool for the first time. Shouto and Inasa didn't register as detectives. Instead, they behaved like newly found friends and cracked jokes with him and Izuku. They appeared like normal high school sweethearts

who were on vacation. Jirou and Momo were smiling in a friendly manner, asking them about their trip down memory lane with the comics.

Then, in all their over enthusiastic glory, were Eijiro and Mina. The two had bright, beaming grins on their faces and were overjoyed to have everyone together for their last night in Paradise. The couple was sporting a giant pink and red bag that read ‘Manliness.’ They proclaimed they had some manly goodies to give to the group once they arrived at the carnival.

And when they did, it was exactly how Katsuki remembered.

He wasn’t sure if that was a good thing or a bad thing when a strange feeling settled into his core.

The smell of buttery popcorn, salty pretzels, and flavor filled treats wafted into the air. Crowds of people were filing into the entrance, passing them all by. Some were people Katsuki recognized from the hotel, or even the camping area. All holding hands and bulked together in groups, giggling and pointing towards the rollercoasters and large Ferris wheel in the background.

Katsuki and Izuku looked up at the same time. Sitting there was that same candy colored arch.

It looked freshly renovated with sparkling new white and red paint. The large, neon sign above them was still in bright, magenta lettering. The ‘C’ no longer flickered like it was broken. Instead, all the letters synchronized in blinking on and off. It flashed enthusiastically, nearly in tune with the exultant music. The glittering lights and dazzling tune screamed ‘come one, come all.’ It drew attention from all corners of the downtown area.

Izuku’s hand squeezed his a little harder as they both stared up at the entrance.

“First up! Before we go inside, Ei and I got something important for everyone!” Mina announced. She held up the large bag, shaking it like a special treat was waiting inside. “It’s super crowded and we don’t want anyone to get lost. So, we went out and bought something that’ll make our group stand out in the crowd. In case we’re separated for any reason.”

She eagerly opened the bag and Katsuki, like a reasonable person, imagined maybe it would be a hat. A sparkly one that was silly and stood out. Maybe even a t-shirt that read ‘World’s Best Paradise Crew.’ But no. Of course, leave it up to the fucking hot pink and blazing red duo to open that goddamn bag and bring out six matching pink boas.

Everyone’s expressions lit up at the sight of the long bundle of feathers. Katsuki made a sound of deep disgust. Izuku tilted his head and hummed like a curious fox. Shouto and Inasa were nearly indifferent and Momo and Jirou were taken aback slightly.

Every muscle that Katsuki used to frown kicked into action. He glowered when the husband-and-wife duo started donning the boas around everyone’s neck.

“This is…festive,” Momo commented with a curious curl at the end. She picked up one end of the boas and whipped it playfully towards her girlfriend.

“Alright. I’m not sorry, but these are fucking ridiculous,” Katsuki deadpanned. He didn’t even bother biting his tongue. “You can’t be fucking serious.”

“We’re extremely serious, bro!” Eijiro exclaimed. He placed Izuku’s boa around his neck, wrapping it twice. “Separation is not something to take lightly. Mina and I were reading that a handful of people have gone missing around Okinawa recently. We freaked out! It would be totally awful if something happened on our last night here. We want to make sure we take all the right precautions.”

Mina wrapped the boa around Katsuki’s neck and grinned playfully.

The soft tickle of feathers against skin was a sensation Katsuki didn’t quite think he’d ever feel. He was about to say something further but reframed when he thought about the ‘missing people’ part of Eijiro’s spill. Despite everything, the two gym aficionados were right. Seems like Moore’s kidnappings were tracking across Okinawa, just not tracked back to him. They should still be mindful.

Izuku lifted his own boa and tickled underneath Katsuki’s nose with the feathers until he sneezed.

Katsuki whipped around, surprised, but was taken back at the absolute adorable expression Izuku had. The doe-eyed man giggled under his breath and his blushing face was slightly tucked into the boa. The hand intertwined with his squeezed lightly.

“Let’s have a good time tonight,” Izuku said with a candid grin. “What do you say?”

The music picked up and the roaring of the rollercoasters from inside grew louder. The blue and pink neon colors flashed and twinkled against both of their faces as they locked eyes. The young part of Katsuki’s soul cheerfully beamed and he found himself easing into letting go.

“Alright. Let’s have some fun.”

“Group picture time!” Mina announced, holding up a pink polaroid camera.

Everyone started laughing and shuffled in together. Katsuki knocked shoulders with Shouto as they all pressed into one big bundle. Izuku easily slid into his arms and Katsuki found himself holding on to him tighter than he usually would. Eijiro held up the selfie-stick and made a peace sign accompanied by his sharp, toothy grin. He began counting down for everyone to smile.

“On three: Paradise crew!” Eijiro said. “One, two, three!”

“Paradise Crew!” Everyone sang in unison.

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki used to wonder what it would feel like to have the power to rewind time.

When he was only just a kid, he imagined that if he was a superhero like All-Might, he would hope his power would be phasing through the past. He would vividly daydream about going back in time to that day his mother found him. He imagined full of longing that he could force her to stay and wait for Izuku. He even imagined a different reality that Izuku showed up on time, and they walked into the carnival holding hands. Maybe then he would have never been found. Maybe then they would have stayed together.

He clung so hard to those daydreams like they were the last molecule of oxygen inside of a chamber. But there were always gaps in them. Pieces of the dream would go black, skip or glitch. He could never imagine the side of the carnival, like a sky high mental roadblock. He had no clue either what they would do together once inside. And he was always too tethered to his hurt to ever look up carnivals again.

But now, as they were fully immersed in the setting, Katsuki felt like he was living out his daydream that he could rewind time.

Izuku was laughing, giggling, and pointing at all the neon things around him. The carousel. The bumper cars. The light up signs that read ‘Fun House’ and ‘Marriage Drive Thru.’ It was all in the spirit of youth as their group went station to station. The reflection of all the flashing lights caught in Izuku’s rose tinted glasses the entire time.

Big, pretty green eyes looked up at Katsuki like he was a beautiful illusion. That unknown emotion rattled in Katsuki’s core again when Izuku gave him that look.

The first thing they did was get dragged to an aerobatics show by Mina.

Their group sat in the high stands, watching in amazement as impossibly flexible humans in glow in the dark leotards did flips and leaps. The dazzling performers mimicked birds in the sky with how aerodynamic they were. Twirling, flipping, and swooping down into dangerous nose dives. The ribbons attached to their bodies were like liquid fabric as intricate patterns were painted in the air.

Izuku had let go of his hand to stand up and cheer when one impressive move was executed.

“That was so cool!” Izuku exclaimed with a tiny gasp. He rocked from his heels to his toes with his hands excitedly clamped together. He whirled around with a giant grin. “Did you see that?!”

Katsuki smiled. “Yeah I did, darling.”

He hadn’t.

He had been too distracted observing Izuku’s facial expressions. The freckled face shifted from impressed, joyful and astonished so fluidly it was more captivating than the show they were watching. He was charmingly emotive in a way Katsuki never noted before.

His faux husband grinned at him and turned back around to give a big cheer to the performers. Some of them caught sight of the excited man and gave him a personal bow that made Izuku squeal happily. When Izuku sat back down, Katsuki wove their fingers together again. He held Izuku's warm hand in his lap with both of his as they continued to watch the show.

Neither one of them noticed the way they were leaning into each other.

☽ ☽ ☽

Their next stop was walking around and looking at all the various carnival games.

All the booths were uniformly aligned in endless rows and uniquely decorated. Some had flashing purple and green fairy lights that competed with the fancy merry go round in the center of the park. Others were filled to the brim with teddy bears and colorful paper flowers glued to the sides of the booths. Their group made their rounds to the different booths, enjoying the time together.

Katsuki won the strongman game that was lit up with bright white lights. He hit the high striker with such force that it damn near left a dent in the bell. The booth worker looked at him with a little bit of fear but gave him the blue-ribbon prize. Pinned it right above his heart and Izuku laughed the entire time.

As they continued on walking, Katsuki observed the various stuffed animals. There were pink ones, blue ones. There were even matching orange and green ones. However, he scoffed in surprise at the All-Might themed teddy bear that was sitting inside of one.

It was fluffy, and its fake fur was artificially colored with yellow, red and blue dye. It even had a red cape pinned to its shoulders giving it the full effect of the superhero movies. Katsuki tilted his head because viewing it now was odd; he had wanted that thing so badly as a kid. Now, he felt like he missed the chance to ever have it. He was far too old to want it at his age, and he reminded the young side of his spirit of that when an unreasonable bitterness settled in.

Izuku noticed his prolonged stare.

"Do you want it?" Izuku asked him.

"Naw, just looking," Katsuki said. He brushed it off, willing away the bitterness. "It's funny seeing it, y'know? It was advertised in the back of one of the comics we used to read. Do you remember?"

"I do. You like it a lot."

"Liked," Katsuki corrected the tense. "I'm too old for things like that now."

Izuku pursed his lips slightly. "But no one is ever too old for things that make them happy."

Katsuki tilted his head curiously at Izuku for that.

Before he could rebut, Izuku's face hardened with resolve. The man began zealously pulling him by their joined hands towards the location of the teddy bear. Katsuki protested immediately. He hissed, nearly slipping up on Izuku's real name when they found themselves in a mind tug-of-war. But eventually Katsuki relented. Turns out, Izuku was as stubborn as a ram. He yanked Katsuki until they stood in front of the booth that had the All-Might teddy bear dangling up above.

Katsuki finally looked at what type of game it was, and he was only a tiny bit surprised to read 'knife throwing' in a big, blown-up typewriter font.

The back wall of the booth was full of red and white bullseyes, gleaming in the light. Izuku waved down the worker who had on a colorful top hat with a big grin. Several other people lined up as well, interested in participating. The worker gave his rehearsed spiel with an award-winning grin and handed everyone ten tiny knives that weren't sharp enough to hurt anyone. The worker did a small bow before signaling everyone to begin.

It was barely a competition when everyone threw the first knife. Katsuki was curtly reminded that Izuku was still very much lethal. The sight snapped him right out of his nostalgia filled daze.

Izuku hit every single bullseye dead center with a sickening sweet smile. The level of accuracy stunned the booth worker and the other carnival goers. When Izuku threw the last knife, lodging it deep in the wood with the high-pitched sound of the metal vibrating, it caused some attention to be drawn.

Shouto and Inasa gaped with pinched brows as everyone else in their Paradise Crew cheered loudly for them. Even the worker gawked at the precision. He walked up to each knife, flicked it and hummed in approval. He turned to congratulate Izuku and handed over the large teddy bear.

Katsuki unwillingly envisioned young Izuku again and all his purity. Then he looked at the twelve bullseyes in front of him that had knives lodged into them in a way only an expert could achieve. The disharmony of the past Izuku and the present one clashed again as Katsuki struggled to maintain focus.

"Um, here. For you," Izuku said nervously.

Katsuki peeled his eyes away from the bullseyes to see Izuku looked up at him with an awkward smile. The shorter man pushed the teddy bear into his arms with a kindhearted gaze. There was a worried air around him as Katsuki took the teddy bear in his arms.

"Thanks," Katsuki said with a small smile.

"No problem at all." Izuku curiously glanced between him and the doll while twisting his metal ring. "I-I'm glad you have it now."

Katsuki looked down at the bear in his hand, and his thoughts dived deep into his childhood memories. He stroked the bear's artificial fur under his calloused hand and the young part of

him cheered happily. That side of him wanted to hug Izuku, and act as though they hadn't been at each other's throats for the latter half of their lives.

Katsuki studied the way Izuku blushed and toyed with his pink boa.

The sight in front of him caused his heart to skip one beat. Two beats. Three beats.

However, he struggled to overlap the two Izukus, they glitched when they got too close. Big, pretty green eyes were swirling in his mind and Katsuki's veins were pumped full of questions. Questions that he wasn't sure he could ask without ruining the moment.

His heart struggled with that nameless emotion.

☽ ☽ ☽

As Katsuki grappled with trying to understand what the unknown feeling was, Izuku fed him with their joint hands all night.

Never in a million years did Katsuki think he'd be thankful for a hideous teddy bear, but as he stared down at it, he smiled. Then he smirked privately at Izuku when the man wasn't looking with his heart beating loudly. Izuku was gazing around, too full of wonder as he pointed to the clowns and street performances.

Eventually, they all agreed to go on the Ferris wheel after stuffing themselves with churros and cotton candy. Truthfully, had this happened a couple of days ago, Katsuki would've grumbled and fussed. He would have said this was cliché and stupid to mask his true emotions about romance.

He had gotten so used to automatically turning his nose up at anything that reminded him of the painful separation. But now, with Izuku's hand intertwined with his, he didn't really feel the need. It was odd. He didn't feel defensive all the way anymore, and Katsuki was questioning why that was.

He glanced between the stuffed animal and then to Izuku inquisitively.

"Have you ever been on a Ferris wheel?" Izuku asked as they stood in line. His voice was hush but bubbling with excitement.

"Nope," Katsuki said with a pop at the end. He focused on the tiny caressing Izuku was still doing with his thumb. "This will be my first time."

"Me too. I guess we can experience it together."

Katsuki could feel the years spent apart wading between them. He wondered how frequently Izuku thought about going to this carnival. More so, he wondered if Izuku thought about going with him—or at least the younger version of himself. Katsuki pursed his lips as he looked behind them in line. He stared at the other couples in their group who were happily laughing.

As they got closer to the front, Katsuki studied the large Ferris wheel. The carts on the thing had different colored hoods. Yellow. Pink. Blue and soft lavender. Every time it rotated, it stopped briefly at the top, letting each set of passengers enjoy the view before they began their descent down.

When they finally arrived at their turn, Momo gave them a sweet thumbs up. It was clear the therapist was overjoyed at the lack of arguing him and Izuku had done all day. Katsuki tsked under his breath.

The kind carnival worker helped them inside of the cart with a welcoming smile. Izuku scootched in happily and Katsuki ducked as he sat next to Izuku in the color cart. He plopped the teddy bear on the side that Izuku didn't sit on. As he looked around the cart, he was impressed. Twinkling fairy lights glittered on and off inside, setting a soft mood in the dark night.

The wheel started their incline up, and Katsuki turned his eyes to the window.

They lifted up and up until they made it about a quarter of the way. It almost felt like they were birds in the sky, a type of freedom that Katsuki wasn't sure he'd ever felt. The people in the crowd became progressively tinier as the sounds drowned out in the background. All the mixed lights flashed, dazzled, and danced in Katsuki's vision as they looked overhead above the carnival.

It looked just as magical as he daydreamed it would all those years ago.

"Are you enjoying the sights?" Izuku said suddenly.

Katsuki turned his gaze. He locked eyes with Izuku, who had been staring at him for who knows how long. Izuku's expression was entirely tranquil. He was once again twisting the metal ring around his finger. Katsuki subconsciously touched him lightly.

"I am," Katsuki agreed, smiling at Izuku. "You seem like you're enjoying yourself a bit more."

"I think so, hah." Izuku smiled timidly while shrugging his shoulders. "Only attempting to make my best of it while we're here."

A piece of Katsuki silently admired Izuku for that.

He learned there was a side of Izuku that *always* tried to make the best of any situation.

Izuku made the best of them being stuck together—even when they couldn't stand the other. He made the best of Katsuki's issue when he didn't understand how to pretend to be in love. He made the best of the boat ride. The beach. The camping trip. Even the cooking class. Katsuki started to see another alignment of Izuku's core as he thought about their past.

Young Izuku made the best of that abandoned church for him too.

Izuku always brightened up the things he touched.

“Did you ever think about coming here? After I disappeared?” Katsuki asked as they rose higher in the sky.

“Of course. I thought about it all the time, I always wanted to go to this place.” Izuku tilted his head at him. “I know this is silly, but I thought a lot about coming back here with you. It feels…nice that we’re here. Together.”

Katsuki smiled again. For once, he didn’t feel alone in his thoughts of dismay in an odd way. The younger part of his spirit hummed happily, settling into a security he hadn’t felt in ages. Or maybe he hadn’t ever really felt it. He never felt remotely understood a day in his life, and his sliver of understanding from reconnecting with Izuku was touching a piece of him he thought didn’t exist.

He gazed on at Izuku, and a state of vulnerability settled in his chest.

“Me too,” Katsuki confessed. He had not a clue *why* he was confessing to that—but he did. “I…I thought about it a lot when I was a kid too. Sometimes I even imagined that if I found this carnival again, you’d just be here. Waiting. Especially because we always kept rambling about all that silly shit. The stuff about *always* coming *back* to each other. It’s fucking stupid, I know given that’s not how marriages works and were just kids clinging to some dumb thing that made us happy.”

The wind lightly howled between them. The silence that fell upon them wasn’t like the other silence they found themselves trudging through. This time it was comfortable. This time it was full of understanding gazes.

Izuku leaned into him when another chilly night-breeze blew in through the cart.

The warmth radiated off of the other body in a gentle way as he drew closer in the car until their legs touched. Katsuki could feel the tone shift, the wind blew the cart as they reached near the peak of the Ferris wheel.

As they grew closer to the top, the view only grew more captivating. The tiny colorful lights down below mimicked an ocean of sparkling stars. Katsuki privately thought Izuku was striking against that backdrop. He waited for Izuku to look out the window and enjoy the view, but pretty green eyes never looked away from him.

“Y’know, it’s fascinating,” Izuku said. “How it all worked out.”

“What do you mean?”

“Despite everything, we still came back to each other.”

His heart filled with unexpected warmth.

“I guess we did. Didn’t we?” Katsuki whispered in a hush manner.

He hadn’t considered it. He hadn’t even pieced together that small fact but suddenly that tiny four-letter word called ‘fate’ came fumbling forward.

Scarlet eyes considered Izuku in all his closeness as he looked into the deep green eyes. He surveyed the moment and the way Izuku twiddled with his ring and only then did Katsuki realize he was gripping his. A small green curl of Izuku's fell forward on his forehead and his hair gently swayed with the breeze.

There was a swelling pull in his chest towards Izuku again.

It pulled him closer and closer to Izuku as he stared at the man underneath the twinkling lights. Izuku studied him back, and soon there was a small brush of their fingers. It sent tiny traces of electricity that climbed all the way up Katsuki's nape. His eyes flickered down to Izuku's lips, and Izuku wordlessly intertwined their fingers together.

The pulling in his chest became more forceful when Izuku shyly tilted his head and leaned in. Katsuki lifted up his other hand to cradle Izuku's soft cheek—make sure he was real and so was this moment. Katsuki tilted his head too, counting one freckle, two freckles, three freckles, four. He leaned in closely until he could hear Izuku's quickened breathing and feel his exhale against his lips.

The cart stopped at the top and time stood still for Katsuki.

Izuku had fluttered his eyes shut and the beautiful carnival setting behind him arranged the perfect, romantic atmosphere. The gorgeous man in front of him was leaning into his touch as he laid himself out bare. Delicate curls were as soft as Katsuki imagined as he twirled one around his finger. Even the gentle air was like hands pushing him down to kiss Izuku. He wanted to. He wanted to so badly. Anyone with eyes could see it was a perfect moment to do so.

But as Izuku leaned in all the way, Katsuki's guilty heart weighed down with a revelation.

"This…This is my last assignment," Katsuki whispered right before Izuku's lips touched his.

Izuku's eyes snapped open.

Izuku's pupils shifted, dilating before constricting as he homed in on Katsuki. The ache in Katsuki's chest tripled when Izuku's face twisted from confusion to mild distress. His faux husband cautiously leaned backwards and Katsuki did too, and they regarded each mutely. The hand intertwined with his retracted. The absence left him feeling cold.

Izuku opened his mouth, snapped it shut and then furrowed his brows.

"What do you mean this is your last assignment?" Izuku asked with an edge. He reached a shaky hand up to slide his heart shaped glasses on top of his head so he could stop viewing Katsuki through the rose-tinted hue. "Last like you're being fired?"

"Last as in after this I'm retiring for good," Katsuki whispered, feeling regretful for unspoken reasons. "I filled my quota and contract requirements."

Izuku stared at him in disbelief like he didn't quite understand that concept. His face crumbled in uncertainty and the magical atmosphere around them became dull.

The feeling of the plastic underneath them in the Ferris wheel cart was suddenly uncomfortable. All the roaring noises of the rollercoasters and the crowd played like static noise in the background. The lights didn't seem as shiny, and the sensation of amorousness denigrated out of the air. Like someone had burned the feeling down to the ground.

He and Izuku stayed in a gridlocked moment in time as the cart swayed slightly in the breeze. The sound of the creaking metal bolts reached Katsuki's ears.

"Does that mean you'll stop overlapping on my assignments?" Izuku murmured.

The wheel started moving again, bringing them down gradually.

"Yes," Katsuki said. He clenched his fists in his laps. "I'm moving to the far countryside to settle down for a long time. I, uh, actually own a bit of property out there that I don't use. I was going to set up in that town. It's quiet. Safe. Y'know, normal."

Izuku's beautiful green eyes drowned in blue melancholy. "…We're never going to see each other again after this. Are we?"

"I mean you could—" *come visit me.*

Katsuki halted when he realized how ridiculous that sounded.

Bitterness grew ripe in Katsuki's veins when he comprehended that suggestion wasn't practical. It was written across Izuku's face too that he understood the words that caught on Katsuki's tongue. But it was more evident he understood why it wasn't possible.

Because despite everything the last two days, they weren't seven anymore.

They couldn't hide under the covers and act as though the last seventeen years hadn't happened. They couldn't act as if they weren't simply two people who collided once, and then happened to collide again in this vast universe like doomed comets. Katsuki knew they couldn't pretend as if they hadn't spent more time hating each other than they ever did loving each other as blissfully ignorant children.

Izuku's hands started nervously plucking at the pink feathers on the boa. One by one the delicate feathers floated unceremoniously to the ground.

Izuku stared around the romantically lit cart, speechless.

They remained in the suffocating limbo as the Ferris wheel stopped moving. Probably letting some other couple above them enjoy the picturesque view they squandered. Their cart rocked a bit, squeaky iron echoing with all the overwhelming carnival sounds. They stayed quiet as the mechanical wheel let them down, getting closer to the ground one click at a time.

Suddenly, the unknown emotion came flooding back the moment Izuku dared glancing at him.

Katsuki couldn't turn his eyes away from Izuku's. Gorgeous green eyes were glossy with the start of tears and there was no mask of emotions on Izuku's face. He gazed fully vulnerable at

Katsuki with unfiltered, raw longing. Katsuki's heart skipped, and he felt that unknown emotion swell until it filled his entire rib cage, spilling over.

Then it clicked. He finally identified what the unknown emotion in his chest was.

It was yearning.

The Ferris wheel stopped once more, but this time it was their cue to exit the ride. The young worker greeted them with a happy grin but neither Izuku nor Katsuki returned it. They looked at her like the sky was full of rain clouds and someone had poured ice water on them.

Izuku hopped out of the cart like he was on fire, legs wobbly. Katsuki slowly climbed out. His heart hammered like a beating drum in his chest. The loud percussion of his pumping blood filled his ears and drowned out the loud noises in the background. His eyes were slightly wide as he stared at the gravely ground underneath his shoes.

Pining.

He was fucking *pining*—for *Izuku*.

Then his heart pulsed with a painful splinter as he thought about young Izuku.

The visual of the past and present glitched as he thought about the knife throwing. But then he thought about the kind hugs. But then his mind raced to the two bullets lodged in his biceps that dangerously nicked his vitals as he was left to bleed out. But once more he imagined Izuku tucking him in at night—but the recollection jumbled and this time instead of young Izuku tucking him in it was present day Izuku.

Katsuki's chest convulsed a bit.

Suddenly, he wasn't too happy about the police raid being so soon. He needed more time to piece things together. No. *They* needed more time.

Why did they always need more time?

He turned to Izuku who had his head hanging downwards, not looking at him. He clutched one arm with body language that curled into himself. He appeared almost as if he wanted to disappear. His brows were pinched together, and his eyes were slowly becoming wetter and glassier. The pair waited off to the side for the rest of their group to get off the Ferris wheel in awkward silence.

Katsuki eventually found his voice again. He stepped towards Izuku, following that stupid pull that was plaguing his chest.

"Izuku—" he started but choked on his words when the man stepped backwards.

Izuku lifted a shaking hand and snapped his heart shaped glass back over his eyes. The rose tint acted like a veil, shielding the heavy emotions that laid behind it. To the ignorant eye, Izuku looked joyous when he offered up a strained smile. But to Katsuki, he could see the desperate denial that was overtaking him.

“L-Let’s make the best of what’s left of the night,” Izuku quickly said. He nervously plucked more feathers from the boa. He nodded dutifully. “No real reason to focus on that. Right?”

“Izuku,” Katsuki said, disappointment heavy in his vocal cords. He tilted his head, unsure if he liked the approach Izuku was taking. “Is what I said bothering you—”

“—Man! That was so fun!” Mina interjected happily from behind them. Their whole group skipped over to them with bright, happy go lucky smiles. Katsuki made a disgruntled sound when their conversation was cut short as Mina slung her arm around Izuku’s neck. “Did you two get a load of that view? It was so lovely!”

“Yeah!” Izuku eagerly agreed. He anxiously plucked more feathers. “It—It was really something.”

“I vote we get drinks next!” Eijiro announced enthusiastically. “That’ll be a great way to end the night.”

Katsuki wanted to object. He wanted to say absolutely not, drag Izuku away and force them to talk. But what about? The fact that he was retiring? Or the fact that they potentially wouldn’t see each other again after finally finding the other. It all was as futile as trying to catch all the grains of time in the palm in his hand. He realized that he was losing Izuku. Once again.

“Drinks sound lovely,” Momo sighed dreamily. “I saw a pop up bar that had a dance floor! We could relax over there.”

“Sounds great to me,” Shouto agreed. He grabbed his husband’s hand and stroked it lovingly. “This will be a great way to end the night.”

Inasa kissed Shouto’s cheek in a way that made Katsuki’s heart painfully remember the past.

He turned to Izuku; he was also staring longingly at the undercover detectives in front of them. Katsuki was uncertain of what to do next—so he decided to go along with what they had to do: pretend to be in love. However, when he reached for Izuku’s hand, the other man didn’t reach back fully. He brushed it off like he hadn’t seen it, and started chatting with Mina in an upbeat tune.

Everyone began cheerfully chatting and Katsuki found himself drowned out in the background.

Izuku clung to Mina’s energetic energy like someone struggling to stay afloat in the rocky sea. His faux husband struggled to meet his gaze again and Katsuki watched how pretty pink feathers were torn off with nervous ticking.

Pluck after pluck Izuku peeled them away while hanging onto the gripping story Mina was telling. She was emoting with her hands with expressive facial gestures that made Katsuki wonder what she was saying. However, it was static to his ears. Everyone was white noise in the background as he focused on Izuku.

All the colors drained and the only thing Katsuki could see was big, pretty green eyes.

☽ ☽ ☽

They found their way at the pop-up bar that was a small box of a room sitting on the grass. It was as if someone had carved out a room from a house and placed it on the lawn. Flashing pink, green, and purple neon lights were lit up all over and the sound of a synth heavy song played over their heads.

Inside, it felt bigger as it was packed shoulder to shoulder with people. The front of the bar had a well lit stage that was elevated. Spotlights beamed down from the ceiling onto the wooden stage, illuminating the row of dancers covered in feathers and glitter. The attractive stage performers shimmied and moved their limbs in an enticing manner as they threw confetti onto the crowd.

Their group was able to secure a table off to the side of the square dance floor. The reflective panels of the dance floor looked like someone had hand polished them until not a scuff was visible. Perfect reflective light from the neon lights above was captured on the dance floor, illuminating the whole room.

Katsuki quickly learned that the Ashido-Kirishimas were drinkers. Heavy drinkers who had deep wallets that were part of the exclusive ‘Manliness’ sports line. The husband-and-wife duo bought everyone a round of drinks until their hearts filled. Izuku heavily drank as did Katsuki.

He was never one to pass up on free alcohol, but the ache inside of his chest was begging to be drowned out and several shots of vodka were doing the fucking trick.

His vision swirled a bit. It swayed like he was on a boat around the third shot and second cocktail.

Izuku’s face was perfectly flushed as pink as his glasses. Drunk giggles and cheers were tossed about and eventually their group all stood up to go dance. The happy couples were whisked away by the high energy, but Katsuki stayed behind. He could feel that buzz in his stomach and lull in his head when he was tittering the line between drunk and obliterated.

When Izuku stole a glance at him again, Katsuki envisioned young Izuku standing there, lost in the crowd.

He grimaced.

Katsuki promptly ordered a pink martini to suppress whatever the fuck that was. He downed it rapidly, enjoying the swimming feeling in his head. Everyone was swinging, shaking, and moving their feet to the beat—truly dancing the night away.

Out of everyone, Izuku seemed the most blissful. He danced like it was possible to sweat out his sadness through his pores. Desperate. Nearly needy. His eyes were closed, and head tilted back as he blissfully allowed Mina and Jirou to twirl him.

He stared at Izuku as the newfound sensation in his chest doubled—tripled—damn near *quadrupled*. Katsuki had never pined for anyone before. Or at least, not since he was a kid. It only added to the growing irony that the one person he pined for as a kid was Izuku.

Now here they were, and he was pining for him all over again.

As Izuku danced in the crowd, Katsuki wistfully watched him.

With each passing song, the vision of young Izuku and present Izuku blended together. The pieces molded together without the middle under the flashing neon lights. Katsuki's heart sparked with relief that he had finally found the missing boy. Visions of them laying together in the nook flashed in and out of his mind. The bright neon lights in the bar reminded him of the glittering stained glass of the abandoned church.

Katsuki took a sip of his drink when his heart clenched.

As the night progressed, Katsuki was unable to move from his chair. He remained perfectly nailed in place by woeful nostalgia.

But that apparently was entirely unacceptable to drunk Izuku.

The man caught his gaze in the dizzy neon lights. He marched over to Katsuki, tripping slightly in the thick wall of bodies but expertly keeping his drink upright so it didn't spill. As Izuku approached him, he chugged down his bright orange drink without breaking eye contact. He slammed the empty glass down on the wooden surface in front of Katsuki with a challenging glare.

He swayed on his feet slightly and Katsuki instinctively steadied him by his hips. But Izuku didn't seem grateful as he leaned down and pouted at him.

"Come dance with me," Izuku demanded with a slur. Izuku jabbed his finger into his chest with a deep pout. "You—*We're* supposed to be making the *best* of the night and you're sitting here like a grumpy cat."

"Maybe I don't wanna dance with you because you didn't hold my hand," Katsuki shot back sarcastically. The warmth of the alcohol in his belly tickled him as he chuckled, not fully in control. "That's what you fuckin' get, darling."

"Only because you didn't tell me you were going to retire." Izuku clumsily grabbed his hand. Katsuki gripped it back. "Why didn't you tell s'me sooner?"

"Why the hell would I have told you?"

"Because we're *friends*!" Izuku shouted angrily above the music. "You should have said something! This—this whole time I thought we would see each other again but we're *not*. You're supposed to tell your friends these things."

"We haven't been friends since we were eight," Katsuki deadpanned. "We've tried to kill each other on multiple occasions after that."

“No.” Izuku shook his head and frowned. “No. No. *No*. We’re *friends*. You’re the closest thing I’ve ever had to a friend, and I’ve *never* tried to kill you, so stop saying that! You should have told me you were going to leave be-because that makes me sad.” Izuku’s voice trailed off into unsteadiness.

“And why does that make you sad?” Katsuki asked with a sneer, slurring his words. “You should be happy to be rid of me. Didn’t you say, and I quote, if we were in the MCU you’d *personally* stop the Avengers from reversing the Snap if it meant that I’d come back?”

“Yeah.” Izuku stared at him hard and chewed his bottom lip. “But I didn’t mean that.”

His green eyes were only slightly visible behind the pink hued glasses. The lenses were reflecting the dancing neon lights, hiding his emotions. As Izuku gazed at him, all the flashing colors blended together like a hypnotic swirl as Katsuki tried to focus. He struggled, however, and he decided he wanted to see Izuku’s pretty eyes without the veil of pink.

Katsuki carefully used both hands to slide the glasses on top of Izuku’s head. His heart swelled when he finally could see the doe eyes without any obstruction.

Izuku stared at him longingly and grabbed his hands. He carefully interlaced their fingers and pulled himself close to Katsuki.

“I looked forward to seeing you,” Izuku gently confessed. “You make me happy in a terrible way.”

Katsuki’s heart tugged and soared hearing that, and his younger spirit smiled. Izuku leaned all the way into him, head bopping with drunkenness as he rested their foreheads together. Katsuki knew then he was a doomed man when the minty smell of Izuku’s cologne reached his nose.

After that, it all became a blur. Mina came back over, insisting that she buy them one more round, and Shouto and Jirou were both pink in the face from drunken laughter. Inasa was patting some of the sweat off his body in the warm room with a pink napkin. So much was happening around them, but all Katsuki could think about was Izuku.

Izuku. Izuku. *Izuku*.

Sweet, adoring Izuku who was leading him by the hand through the dance crowd. Katsuki goofily smiled the entire time, hoping the night would never end.

He’d dance here for eternity with Izuku if it meant easing the flustered yearning in his chest.

The alcohol in his system acted like a sweet type of poison as it pumped through his body. All he could really see was streaks of color, and Izuku’s freckled face. They danced in the middle of the room, everything bent and swirled out of shape. Then as the music continued, the melodies stopped reaching Katsuki’s ears. Everything slowed, the music slowly faded and Izuku gradually ceased his dancing.

Izuku hugged him.

There was no warning, no words. Izuku wrapped his arms around him in the middle of that crowded room and suddenly there wasn't a single soul around them anymore. It was just the two of them, underneath the glittering lights. Katsuki was stunted at first, but then gradually he understood. He wrapped his arms around Izuku too, in a silent way of saying 'me too'.

Katsuki looked down at his emerald wedding band and his emotions gave like splintered wood.

After this, they wouldn't be playing pretend anymore.

Yes, they had finally found each other—but in two days, Izuku will be gone. They would go their separate ways and the boy with green eyes would remain a distant, distasteful memory. Katsuki clutched on harder to Izuku who hugged tighter to him in response. They swayed slowly in the dense room as if they were the only two people there.

Katsuki realized that this was once again the end of them. The young side of his spirit fussed. It fussed like the broken child he used to be, nearly stomping its foot. Then it whispered to him that they didn't want to be separated. They wanted to stay—and always come back to each other like they promised.

The last thing Katsuki remembered was staring at their wedding bands.

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki cursed the fucking sun the next morning.

His skull was pounding like someone was using his brain as a taiko drum and his tongue was uncomfortably dry like he had been licking wood all night. He groaned obnoxiously loud and squinted at the source of light that was blaring directly into his face. The flat surface of the mattress shifted under his weight. It was only then did he realize he was laying on top of someone.

What the hell is going on?

Katsuki blinked awake and forcefully slowed himself down to gain his bearings.

His stomach rocked like he was nauseous, and everything in his body felt nearly vile. Katsuki wearily glanced around and surprisingly found himself back in their hotel room. He attempted to recollect how he got from the carnival to the hotel, but only blurry bits and pieces came rushing forward.

It was scattered and full of weird visuals that didn't make sense: Sparkling green eyes. Momo gasping. Shouto tilting his head. He even remembers hearing bells in the blur of colors that were clogging his brain. But overall, none of it connected—or even made fucking sense.

A sinking feeling of dread dropped down to the bottom of his gut. Off to the side was Izuku's violin case that was for some reason open, and the violin was sitting on the bed with him—or them.

Izuku's snoring rippled in the air reminding him he wasn't alone.

Katsuki lifted himself slightly up to find Izuku sleeping underneath him. The other man's legs and arms were wrapped around him like a spider, clinging tightly. Soft hands were running through his hair and there was a giant fucking hickey sitting perched on his freckled neck above his tattooed '217'.

Katsuki grimaced immediately at the sight. Fuck. Fuck Fuck *Fuck*—

He frantically looked down but was relieved to see both him and Izuku were fully clothed.

Izuku's blouse was unbuttoned by two and Katsuki's pants were unzipped but still intact. Everything was intact, actually. It appeared like they stumbled in here, collapsed on the bed and attempted to take off their clothes but fucking failed at it because they were too damn drunk.

He mentally beat himself up because, holy shit, that was the first time he had blacked out in *years*. Much less on an assignment. This was probably one of the bigger mishaps he had ever done. He prayed that he didn't let anything fucking slip to Shouto or Inasa.

How the hell had he been so *thoughtless*?

Then he remembered how fucking sad Izuku looked when he told him he was retiring. Katsuki winced. Right. That's how he had been reckless: trying to drink down his fucked-up feelings about his childhood friend turned nemesis.

He rolled off of Izuku and decided to go get some painkillers for his pounding hangover.

Izuku stirred awake, reaching out for him as he sat up on the side of the bed,

"Katsuki?" Izuku's groggy voice called out for him. "Are you awake?"

"Yeah, I'm up," Katsuki said. He looked down at his clothes in mild disgust. "Do you remember what happened yesterday after the bar by any chance?"

Izuku sat up all the way. Green curls were tossed all around, pointing in every direction. Izuku scrunched his nose and squinted his eyes when the bright sun hit him directly in the face.

"No," Izuku grumbled and sat up too. "I blacked out when Mina gave me my fourth shot of vodka and some fruity sounding drink. I had no clue they would be drinkers like that. Their tolerance is higher than anything I've ever seen."

"Yeah. Leave it up to the fitspo couple to be extreme rage machines," Katsuki grumbled. "Fucking pink and red lunatics."

Izuku mumbled in agreement, grabbing his head, and plugged in his dead phone.

Katsuki stood up from the bed and was prepared to go grab the largest dose of acetaminophen that was in his suitcase. However, when he walked past the wooden nightstand, he stopped short. Scarlet eyes caught the gleam of something that wasn't there before. He whipped his head around towards it with a confused expression.

Sitting there was a neat piece of paper.

It was off white, had a golden seal on it, a blue ribbon, and there was a red emblem stamped in the corner. The gold trimming twinkled in the morning light, beckoning Katsuki to pick it up. Katsuki grabbed it with caution, inspecting it closer and the sound of Izuku's phone turning on could be heard in the background.

He held it closer to his face as he started reading—but his confusion fucking grew more when he processed the title of the document. At the bottom were a sleuth of curvy signatures on dotted lines. One signature looked familiar—familiar like his.

But what was even more concerning were the names on it. Printed in clear, bold font in black ink.

All the color drained from his face.

He attempted to make sense of the paper in his hand as he clutched it till it crinkled. He read the two names over and over. Told himself there *had* to be another explanation. But the more he read it, the more it seemed official. Especially when on the other side was the formal watermark for the city of Nago, Okinawa.

He whirled around to the man who was lying on the bed, still half asleep.

"*Izuku*…Why the *fuck* does this marriage certificate say Bakugou Izuku and Bakugou Katsuki?"

Chapter End Notes

Let me know your screams, questions and theories below! Thanks once again, I appreciate you all. I hope everyone has a happy New Year :) May 2022 be good to you all!

Chapter 9: Maestoso

Chapter Summary

> Maestoso (tempo): Majestically

Chapter Notes

> Hello! Welcome everyone! First, big thank you to Luna for betaing this chapter!! She's truly amazing and such a delight, always ^^ 💜 She has my whole heart.
>
> Next, I hope you enjoy this very special chapter! But before you do, I have links to some really pretty fan art that was done between this chapter and this one!! They're all so awesome. Please give them a look see! Thank you all so much for enjoying this story! It means the world!
>
> Izuku with Knife || Vacation Deku || Bakugou Katsuki || Izuku in Vacation clothes

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 9 - Maestoso

.

.

.

"Maybe it's not real."

"What the hell do you mean it's not real? It looks real as shit, Izuku. It even has the official stamp of Nago, Okinawa on it and says, 'marriage is *legally* recognized in the country of Japan'—*and* it has our goddamn government names on it."

Katsuki wanted to slap himself. Or maybe he wanted to slap Izuku. Or possibly slap both him and Izuku at the same time in one fell swoop. He sat down on the edge of the stupid fucking heart shaped bed in horror and rested his head in his palms.

"I-It could be one of those fake marriage thingys!" Izuku reasoned in a high-strung tone. He stared at the daunting piece of paper, thinking that it *couldn't* be real. He was visibly sweating, clearly sick to his stomach as he gawked at their names that were in crisp, black

ink. “W-We should go find out where we got this from—it might not even be legally binding.”

Katsuki scowled. “And if it fucking is?”

Izuku’s stunned face twisted in confusion. He didn’t utter a word as he glanced between Katsuki and the piece of paper.

“I-It can’t be,” Izuku eventually spoke, fully in denial. “Your surname isn’t *actually* Bakugou, is it? I thought that was fake.”

Katsuki scoffed. “Of course it’s my real surname. Why would I lie about that?”

“But *why* would you use your real surname for an assignment?” Izuku hissed, now looking incredibly upset. “Th-That’s plain reckless and extremely poor undercover behavior. I don’t ever reveal my real surname *or* first name on assignments—”

“—Look, the surname thing, *sure*. I probably should’ve checked in with a fake one,” Katsuki quipped unhappily. “But, in my fucking defense, I figured this would be a one and done type of assignment: a bullet in that scummy bastard’s skull from a rooftop in the dead of night and then I would *leave*. I didn’t anticipate I would get up close and personal with the son of a bitch. And neither did my supervisor—but here we fucking *are*.”

Izuku made a disgruntled sound and clutched the roots of his hair.

“I can’t believe Bakugou is your real last name,” Izuku muttered, eyes staring wide at the marriage certificate.

“Well, Bakugou might be *your* real surname name too if we don’t fucking figure this out,” Katsuki reminded him curtly. “So back to the question: what do we do?”

“W-We’ll figure it out as we go,” Izuku said wearily. He placed down the paper with shaky fingers onto the nightstand. Both of them stared at it like it was Satan’s spawn. “I-In the meantime we—we need to figure out if it’s real before even considering what happens next. I still don’t think it’s legitimate.”

A brash, sarcastic chuckle escaped from Katsuki. “Let’s *really* fucking hope so.”

Izuku then looked down at his clothes and Katsuki did too. He cringed. *Fuck*.

They both were still wearing their outfits from the night before, crumbled and disheveled. There was a light waft of the smell of alcohol on them and getting a whiff of it made Katsuki’s stomach churn in repulsion.

He then observed Izuku and grimaced to the point he practically flinched. It was somehow even worse for the smaller man. Sitting there, nearly taunting him, was an *extremely* large hickey on Izuku’s neck. It was about the size of his fist, reddish purple and it appeared as though someone had spent an *extremely* long time sucking. Multiple bite marks up and down Izuku’s whole collarbone were evident.

Katsuki sucked at his teeth. His, hopefully still, faux husband hadn't even noticed yet. Izuku's eyes remained glued to the marriage certificate and his hand was clasped over his mouth in utter shock.

There were so many goddamn problems right now.

Which to tackle first? Katsuki for once in his life didn't know where to begin. So, he started with the obvious problem: his wardrobe. He stood up and zipped up his fly and buttoned his pants when could see he was nearly undressed below the waist. He didn't even have fucking socks on. Who the hell takes their socks off first? Katsuki wanted to slap his drunk self for thinking so goddamn *backwards*.

The sound of the zipper made Izuku's eyes whip down to his crotch area. His brows pinched together.

"D-Did we—" Izuku swallowed nervously. "Did we do *it*?"

Katsuki scoffed at the innocent language. "Can you walk properly?"

"Yeah?"

"Then I think it's safe to assume, no."

Izuku's eyes widened at that.

Katsuki gave Izuku an unimpressed stare in return as he smoothed out his rumpled shirt. Impossibly big green eyes darted from Katsuki's crotch to his face. The creaky gears turning in Izuku's head were practically audible and they were running a mile a minute. When it clicked, Izuku blushed and hastily turned away.

"O-Okay, well, that's a non-issue," Izuku muttered timidly, eyes darting in every direction but towards Katsuki. "Er, let's get ready for breakfast and see if anything bad happened last night. If we accidentally let our real names spill to the group, especially Shouto and Inasa, we need to do damage control, *fast*."

"And what exactly would be our excuse for being *Katsuki* and *Izuku*?" Katsuki asked tiredly.

"Roleplaying?" Izuku suggested, entirely unsure and overwhelmed. He grimaced and shrugged his shoulders. "They already think we enjoy doing it in the woods—what's adding in one more kink to the mix?"

Katsuki's expression transformed into deep doubt. Extremely fucking deep doubt. They were dealing with two detectives, and despite Katsuki thinking cops were dumb, they weren't *that* dumb. Shouto and Inasa were already partially suspicious of them—but at this point, he'd take any excuse.

"Sure, why the fuck not." Katsuki threw his hands up with a huff. "Forest sex kink, shitty martial issues, plus I'm apparently a fucking *brute*—why not add random ass drunk roleplaying to the mix? Hell, let's just tell them we're here to kill the guy they're attempting to arrest while we're at it."

“Look, it’s the best we got.”

“I know, and that’s sad. Really fucking *sad*.”

Izuku nodded in agreement. He wore a puzzled expression that gave away that he was still processing everything. It was a hard concept to grasp. They might’ve not only blown their cover—but possibly were *married*. Izuku shuddered like he had smelled something sour and shook his head. He stole one more glance at the gleaming, gold trimmed certificate before hurrying towards the bathroom.

Izuku fiddled with his fingers as he walked directly in front of the long, full-length mirror on his way.

“I’m going to go get showe—sh-sh—*w-what* is *that*?!” Izuku’s all but screamed.

His shrill voice cut through the air like a whizzing bullet when he caught sight of his reflection. All the color drained from Izuku’s freckled face as he waltzed up closely to the mirror. His face contorted in disbelief as he aggressively tugged the hem of his blouse down. The next sound that erupted from Izuku was a cross between a wheeze and a shriek as he craned his neck to get a better look.

Katsuki winced and held his pounding head more.

“Is this a *hickey*?” Izuku accused. “Katsuki—You gave me a *hickey*?”

“It would appear that way,” Katsuki grumbled. “If it makes you feel any better, I don’t recall doing it.”

“No,” Izuku said flatly. “No, that doesn’t make me *feel* any better.”

He was too tired to counter Izuku’s sarcastic remark. As he sat there, part of him was a little annoyed that he couldn’t remember doing that.

Despite all the awkwardness he and Izuku were trying to navigate, it didn’t fully take away from the fact he still found Izuku beyond attractive. Plus, in light of recent events, he could finally admit he was pining for Izuku. Drunken shenanigans didn’t take away from that. That stupid warm feeling inside of his chest was still burning strong.

Actually, when he examined it, the feelings of affection were *somehow* burning stronger than yesterday. It was hot. Scorching. It virtually threatened to devour him if he didn’t extinguish it soon. The all-consuming need inside of his bones made him deeply want to kiss Izuku. And with the added pressure of their time running thin, the urge was sitting heavy on his nerves. It told him to go to Izuku, *now*, and openly say *fuck it* since they had possibly less than twenty-four hours together before they would likely never see each other again.

However, the fact that he might’ve already done that, and *more,* was a little fucking upsetting. He got the wedding but no goddamn honeymoon.

Izuku’s finger traced a circle around the large spot above his tattoo. “Why is it so big?”

“It, uh, looks like a cluster.”

“A cluster?”

“Multiple hickies in one spot that shape up to be one big hickey.”

Izuku’s eyes caught his through the reflection of the mirror. Katsuki had never burned with such embarrassment with the way Izuku’s green eyes were boring into his soul. The other man was surveying him suspiciously—and Katsuki surveyed him back, but maybe he was simply admiring his handy work. Even while drunk, he had given a wide variety of pretty little marks. Katsuki had to admit, he liked the way Izuku’s lovely skin appeared right now: marked up with his teeth was an excellent fashion on Izuku.

“Are you sure you didn’t punch me in the throat?” Izuku suddenly asked.

“*What*—” Katsuki spluttered in surprise. “Izuku, that is *clearly* a fucking hickey.”

“This looks exactly like the bruise I had when you punched me in the throat in Taiwan, so *excuse me* for having doubts.” Izuku shot him a glare. “But if it is a hickey, then you really do have the world’s biggest mouth. Literally and figuratively.”

Katsuki’s eyebrow twitched.

Of course, he was pining for a goddamn brat.

“...Go get fucking showered.”

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki ended up getting showered first.

Izuku decided he needed time to pace around the room until there was a hole in the floor. The flustered freckled man was muttering a mile a minute about different things. Such as, what the hell were they going to tell the group? If they had let their real names spill, what type of kinky roleplay would involve fake names like Izuku and Katsuki? Then finally, what time was the raid tomorrow and how long did they have left to kill Moore before time was permanently up? However, the marriage wasn’t one of Izuku’s many mutterings.

Both of them were promptly ignoring the elephant in the room that was the shape of a rectangle and stamped with a red seal.

After showering, Katsuki patiently got dressed and told himself it was fine. It was all going to be fucking *fine*. Izuku and him were not married and they had not let their names slip. He took in a sharp, relaxing inhale and stationed himself on the edge of the bed. He couldn’t help nervously tapping his foot after he finished donning himself with his silver chain and black, fang earrings.

As he waited for Izuku to shower, his denial began kicking in full swing.

There was no way they were *really* married—*right*?

Sure, they did things they wanted to and had done as children together yesterday. But their drunk selves wouldn't go get fucking remarried—or, er, *married*. Technically their first stupid little marriage was fake too. But this one, if it was the worst-case scenario, was extremely real. Very real with *very* real consequences.

The weight of the wedding band on his finger was heavier than before. He glanced down at the shining emerald on his hand. It gleamed like it was laughing. He then wearily glanced towards the bathroom door when he couldn't hear the shower running.

"Are you alright in there?" Katsuki called out.

"I-I'm fine—I just—" Izuku stopped short. "I, uh, found more hickies."

"*What*?" Katsuki exclaimed. His eyes went wide.

He used his hand to cover his mouth in shock and prayed that more memories from last night would come to him. How were there *more* hickies? Then it hit him upside his head like a brick: Izuku's blouse had been casually unbuttoned about halfway. Oh. Oh fuck—

"There's a really large one on my chest," Izuku said, sounding peeved. "Right on my nipple. It looks like someone chomped all around it."

Now Katsuki was *really* fucking upset. Why couldn't he remember doing that? Izuku had extremely cute nipples and Katsuki would probably—no, not probably—he would *definitely* sell his left leg just for a chance to bite them. Izuku probably had cute moans too.

Katsuki cursed under his breath and punched the air silently.

☽ ☽ ☽

Izuku emerged from the bathroom wearing a light pink, silk scarf around his neck. It was thin, short and tied neatly into a loosely hanging bow. The piece of delicate fabric hid the large bruise and his tattoo entirely. It fluidly spilled over in front of his simple, white button down. Izuku looked both flustered and pissed when he finally finished putting on his sandals.

"Did you have any hickies?" Izuku asked. His face was twisted in a little pout as they got ready to leave their room. "My entire chest is covered in them."

Katsuki shook his head. "Naw, no hickies."

"How is that fair?" Izuku grumbled under his breath.

Katsuki raised an eyebrow. "Did you *want* me to have hickies too?"

Izuku didn't reply to that.

They both grabbed their key cards, wallets, and when it came time to walk out, they took one last daring glance at the wedding certificate sitting on the nightstand. It was silently mocking

them with the question if it was real or not. Izuku stared at it with a conflicted expression before he turned to leave.

Then quickly a part of Katsuki's dangerous curiosity kicked in.

"Wait," Katsuki called before Izuku could walk out. The other man turned around with an expectant look with his hand on the doorknob. Katsuki cleared his throat and tilted his head. "Can I see it?"

Izuku scrunched his face, puzzled. "See what?"

"The hickey," Katsuki said simply. He gestured to his own chest to emphasize his point.

Izuku stared at him blankly.

"The hickey," Izuku parroted slowly. Katsuki nodded. "You want me to lift up my shirt and let you stare at the *hickey* on my nipple rather than immediately going to figure out if we're legally married or not?"

"…Yeah?"

"I *can't* with you—" Izuku threw his hand up, yanked open the door, and marched out.

Katsuki hurriedly followed him. He didn't see the problem with his question.

"I'm just trying to see if it'll trigger more memories," Katsuki defended as Izuku walked in front of him. A pissed off aura was rapidly emitting from Izuku's small frame. "Maybe seeing it might help me remember what we did last night."

Izuku whirled his head around but didn't stop his stride as he gritted his teeth.

"Shut *up*, Bakugou Katsuki!"

☽ ☽ ☽

Izuku walked ahead of him the entire way down. The freckled man was blushing furiously, and every now and then rubbing his chest like it was tender. That unfortunately made Katsuki question if Izuku had sensitive nipples. Even worse, Katsuki was extremely curious to know how Izuku's chest looked, littered with his marks.

When they arrived for breakfast, they did their best to act cool. Katsuki was the first to initiate the hand holding. Izuku squirmed a bit in discomfort at the contact but went along with it. They still had to *act* like they were married.

The pair grabbed their normal plate full of food and walked over stiffly to their usual table. Katsuki was tense, as was Izuku. Their backs were unnaturally straight, and their eyes were on high alert as they approached. Surprisingly, everyone was chatting like usual. Mina and Eijiro were giving their morning Manliness promotion, Momo doted over Jirou and Shouto looked sleepy. Everyone was relaxed, cool, and calm. Not a soul batted a suspicious eye at them when they sat down. Instead, Inasa smiled at them with a large, overly friendly grin.

“Hey, you two love birds!” Momo said cheerily. A little too cheery, when Katsuki considered it.

Izuku offered a strained smile. “H-Hey! How are you guys?”

“We’re doing pretty good,” Mina replied in a sing-song tune. She was glancing between them with an amused stare. “But more importantly, how are *you two* doing?”

“Hung over,” Katsuki said sharply. He stabbed with his fork at the food on his plate. “Not exactly in the best mood.”

He looked towards Shouto and Inasa at that moment, who were quietly assessing them. Katsuki discreetly analyzed them back, attempting to catch any hint of distrust in their body language. However, he found nothing. In fact, there was nothing negative in any of the other couples’ smiles or stares. It was as though he and Izuku had said something hilarious to them before they had sat down.

Every single one of them were smiling and snickering.

Katsuki grimaced when Jirou choked back a laugh and winked at Izuku. Izuku stared back puzzled, and the two hitmen cut their eyes towards one another. This was both a bad sign and a good one.

What the hell had happened last night?

“W-We actually blacked out,” Izuku said in a rush. The desperation in his voice was thick. “We’re sorry if we said anything strange last night! You shouldn’t take us too seriously. Taro and I can be a little, uh, *imaginative*, when we’re drunk like that.”

“I don’t know if imaginative is the right word,” Eijiro chuckled under his breath.

“I would think ‘*flirty’* is more fitting,” Shouto said. He gave a cool half-smile as he leaned back in his chair. He looked between them with an assumed stare. “You know, I had doubts you two even *liked* each other until last night. But, uh, I guess you two are clearly married for a reason.”

All the blood drained from Katsuki’s face. Oh, fuck. This was much worse.

“W-What do you mean?” Izuku questioned.

Katsuki dreaded what the answer could possibly be.

“Well,” Inasa started, grinning from ear to ear. “After the last round of cotton candy shots, you two started groping each other in the middle of the dance floor. Taro began exclaiming that his husband had the ‘world’s most perfect ass’ and ‘no extra in the world could ever compare’. Then he gave Hiroji’s backside a good slap.”

Kill me, Katsuki begged internally. *Just fucking take me out.*

He lifted his head up to the ceiling and took a deep gulp of air. He was cursing everything right now. He did his best and pushed down all the burning heat that was rising.

He didn't miss the way Izuku glanced towards him curiously.

"Yeah, then Hiroji started rambling on about how strong Taro was," Eijiro said in a hysterical laugh. He chuckled so hard he doubled over, gripping the table for support. "Something about Taro being loaded with multiple types of guns? Then he began pointing to Taro's biceps saying they were dangerous weapons and begged to be choked with them via *sleeper hold* in the middle of the dance floor."

Now it was Katsuki's turn to glance towards Izuku.

Green eyes went wide, and a deep blush raced onto Izuku's freckled face.

"Th-That's hilarious," Izuku said gravely. He tried to mask his embarrassment with a strained high-pitched tone that didn't fool Katsuki. Weary green eyes glanced around at the table accompanying his forced smile. "D-Did anything else happen?"

"Oh, yeah," Jirou chimed in. "After you two were finished groping each other, Hiroji, you said something about you two should get married again?"

"Yeah, which was a little strange," Shouto said, sounding confused. "I asked, 'what for?' and Taro said that it was a good idea because last time you two were married, you were seven. To which I said, 'That's illegal'."

Shouto tilted his head, and it matched the baffling memory in Katsuki's head.

That small gesture triggered other memories in Katsuki's mind. They came tumbling forward, nearly painful since his skull was already pulsing in pain. A tiny piece of the night strung together. He suddenly could remember Shouto telling them there was no way they could have been wed at seven, and if they were they should seek out a lawyer.

Then Katsuki remembered berating Shouto, yelling at him and saying he sounded like his dead mother. Katsuki winced at that. Then, on cue, the memory of Momo gasping in shock pieced in. She told Katsuki he shouldn't talk about his mother like that, and Katsuki aggressively waved her off. Next, he could feel Izuku's warm hand tugging him along. Sparkling green eyes were enticing and Katsuki couldn't say no. He could see them leave the pop-up bar together with drunk, matching smiles.

After that it was a blur.

"And *where* did we go exactly?" Katsuki asked when the memories were cut off.

"To the Marriage Drive Thru at the carnival," Jirou answered simply. "You two said you'd be right back and that we could keep dancing. But, uh, you never came back. We tried looking for you after a while, and we found you two making out at the entrance. Then you said you were going back to the hotel for your honeymoon. We figured you went to go…you know. Do what married couples do after feeling each other up all night."

Izuku gulped heavily and touched the silk scarf on his neck. “Oh. Ha, wow. What a wild night.”

“Extremely,” Katsuki grumbled. “Thanks for filling those gaps in for us.”

“No problem at all!” Mina said with a bright grin. “You two are really fun! It’s been great getting to know you. I’m sad we’re checking out in a couple of hours; I think we would all be awesome friends.”

“Yeah! It’s been super dope!” Eijiro said. He gave an eager thumbs up. “We should have a group chat!”

Katsuki felt a little jealous at how fucking chipper both Mina and Eijiro were.

How the hell were they not hungover? Both of these motherfuckers drank way more than anyone at this table combined. As he watched them act unaffected, Katsuki seriously considered the ‘Manliness’ workout and nutrition plan. If it meant that the Ashido-Kirishimas were immune to alcohol poisoning, then it might actually be a good fucking program.

The conversation shifted into making lighthearted jokes about him and Izuku. They both laughed it off, holding hands the whole time to sell the image. Izuku even pulled down his scarf a bit to show off his hickey to solidify their cover. After a while, everyone eased into another subject about cats. Momo pulled out her phone and started showing pictures of her and Jirou’s ‘fur babies’: Jiji and Stormy. Izuku’s eyes glanced at the picture of the adorable cats and had to agree with the other couple’s assessment that they were indeed the cutest cats in existence.

When everyone was cooing, distracted, Katsuki and Izuku quietly exchanged glances towards each other.

The discreet stare clearly translated various levels of embarrassment. Katsuki thought about what he had said about Izuku’s ass and Izuku thought about how he publicly claimed to want to be choked. But while all that was humiliating as hell, it was good news. They smiled slightly in relief. They hadn’t spilled anything to their Paradise Crew about their names or the real reason why they were here.

In a roundabout way, they had *finally* solidified they were a couple—at the very end of this pain in the ass assignment.

But now one question remained on the table: what occurred at that damn Marriage Drive Thru?

☽ ☽ ☽

They backtracked all the way back to the carnival directly after breakfast. Izuku and Katsuki gave a lame excuse not to spend the day with everyone. They couldn’t think of something all the way plausible on the spot, so Izuku blurted out that he might’ve dropped his wallet at the carnival. Next, Katsuki said he was far too hungover for any more activities and just wanted

to spend the day with his husband. He cringed at the word—it tasted far different in his mouth as it hung over their heads.

Everyone easily believed their excuse, considering how drunk off their asses they had been. They all said goodbye, exchanged phone numbers even though Katsuki had no plans on calling any of these people after this. But he did it in politeness when Jirou hugged him with a smile.

The trek back to the carnival felt oddly similar to walks of shame Katsuki experienced after one-night stands.

All the streetlights, concrete roads and pathways were familiar yet not in the bright daylight. The nighttime magic of the carnival faded entirely, and the atmosphere felt stale, like a bitter aftertaste in his mouth. Almost as though the curtains on a magic show had been pulled back to reveal there was no magic all along. Only smoke and mirrors and he fell for it like a fool.

They stumbled into the carnival area that was majority shut down. Some people were out and about, but the energy was significantly dampened as people passed them without the dazzling music or cheer. The pair of hitmen wandered around, searching for the ‘Marriage Drive Thru’. Eventually they found it neatly tucked away in the corner behind the large merry-go-round. Even the carnival rides seemed different, entirely lackluster without dazzling lights blinking upon them. He could see all the reddish-brown rust and loose screws poking out the machines.

They took a second to pause in front of the Marriage Drive Thru.

They stood side by side in tight trepidation.

The crime scene of their possible fuck up was conveniently placed in a pop-up building. It was sturdy and had the lettering of ‘Marriage Drive Thru’ in a colorful bright yellow and pink font. Each letter was encased by a row of lightbulbs. It probably was alluring and glittery at night—but now it looked bland with the power shut off.

Katsuki cut his eye towards Izuku. The other man was flexing his hands between open and balled up in a fist. After a wide breadth of quietness, Izuku inhaled and turned towards him.

“Let’s hope for the best,” Izuku soothed, unsure.

Katsuki nodded, also slightly unsure. “Yeah. The best.”

They walked into the pop-up building and it was everything Katsuki imagined it to be. The setting was plastic, stiff, and lifeless. It was clearly put together under a tight, low budget. The inside was a poor excuse for a mock church. It even had cheap, wooden benches that were lined up and down, creating an aisle. All over were fake, slightly dingy white flowers, and fairy lights. Katsuki couldn’t tell if they were even on because so many of them had a fuse blown.

In front of them at the end of the aisle was a large wedding arch. It had sheer white drapes and pink flowers entangled upon it. On the top read ‘Just Married!’ in dazzling, glittering

gold cut out lettering. Off to the side was a dusty brown trunk that had wedding props sloppily tossed inside —and someone was reorganizing it, hunched over singing 'Chapel of Love' happily to himself.

"E-Excuse us," Izuku announced as they approached the man. The man rummaging around in the trunk whirled towards them, as though surprised someone was here. "Hi, is there someone we could talk to about the business?"

He was an older gentleman in a tacky, dull grey suit. It was decorated with one of those stupid water squirt corsages pinned directly above his heart. He had a long face, like he was in a perpetual state of shock and had a strange handlebar mustache that twisted on itself on the ends. Katsuki couldn't stop himself from making a displeased face. His upper lip curled.

He sure as hell hope this wasn't the fucking person who married them—fake or not.

"Why yes, hello!" The man said. He gave them a fake, forced grin that Katsuki could see through. Three of his teeth were gold and the other two were silver. "Was there something I could help you two with?"

"Are you the owner by any chance?" Izuku asked nervously.

"Yes I am. Kimoto Yasuo at your service." The man nodded and straightened himself out. He smoothed a hand over his slicked back, thick noir hair and assessed them. "Oh! I remember you two! How is it going? Enjoying the newlywed life?"

Katsuki flinched at the term *'Newlywed.'*

"That's actually what we wanted to talk to you about," Izuku said. He shifted nervously. "W-We found a marriage certificate with our names and the Nago city seal on it. We were trying to see if there had been some mix up or possibly that this was all for show—"

"—We're here to figure out if these marriages are legally binding or not," Katsuki injected non-too-gracefully and got straight to the point. "This shit is all fake, right? Marriage certificate and all?"

Yasuo blanched at them as if he was offended.

"Of course it's not fake," Yasuo said, face twisting in distaste. "All marriages done here are as official as any other marriage sealed elsewhere. We use a civil officiant and bring all the proper paperwork for convenience. All documentation is real and submitted to the city for *permanent* record every morning. If you're married here, you're married legally."

Married.

Legally.

The shock set in instantaneously, and the room swayed—or did he sway?

Katsuki's vision swarmed momentarily with white spots and his stomach did a backflip. Next, the throbbing in his head increased into a high, painful tempo against his temples. He

tried to swallow but his throat was dry and scratchy. Katsuki lifted a shaky hand and gripped his hair in an attempt to alleviate some anxiety.

Married legally. They were fucking married, for real this time.

It was quiet enough to hear the buzzing of some insect in the cramped space. Suddenly, Izuku let out a shaky breath and it reminded Katsuki that someone was next to him in the shifting room. Specifically, his husband.

His fucking *husband*.

Izuku wordlessly stumbled like the ground beneath them was tilting and grabbed for the edge of the aisle benches. He held onto it desperately for support with one hand as he gripped his stomach like he was suddenly sick with the other hand.

Katsuki just stared and stared at the owner's mustache. He couldn't comprehend it. Real? These fucking marriages were *real*? He tried to wrap his mind around it—but he felt like he was sinking in quicksand as he allowed the reality to stir.

"Is there a problem?" Yasuo asked. "If you would like, I could show you the tape from the wedding. For legal purposes, we document all weddings that happen here and then give every couple a copy for sentimental reasons. But, uh, I remember you two didn't exactly wait for me to give you your copy."

Katsuki's brows pinched together. There was even a fucking tape?

He dared to finally look Izuku in the eye. The large, deep green eyes of the other man were unreadable. Izuku stared back at him wordlessly before biting his lip and turning back to the business owner.

"S-Sure," Izuku said, clearly forcing his tongue to form the word.

Izuku stood up straight but still clutched his stomach as though he was seasick. Katsuki turned to the owner too, who gestured for them to follow him to some backroom. With each step Katsuki felt like his body was heavier by tenfold, weighed down by the new information.

They arrived in a tiny, shabby office in the shape of a square. It had several mini fans on, a futile attempt to combat the summer heat. In the center of the room was a single slanted wooden desk and two chairs that looked like they were on the brink of collapse. If someone were to sit in them, Katsuki was sure they would fall straight to the floor. The draft of air circulating the room felt sticky and there was the smell of leftover nicotine lingering around but no cigarettes in sight.

All of this did nothing to ease Katsuki's ever growing anxiety. It gnawed through him the longer he stared around the room.

The owner shuffled through an egregiously disorganized file cabinet that was shoved into the corner. Several loose, single papers were laying around and some of the file drawers weren't

even closed. Edges of manilla folders were stained, burned with cigarette imprints and poking out and bent in places they shouldn't be.

"Here we go!" Yasuo exclaimed, holding up a silver DVD. It shined horribly in the light that was spilling in from the window. "Bakugou Katsuki and Bakugou Izuku. Right?"

"Ye-Yeah," Izuku whispered. "That is, uh, *us*."

Yasuo either didn't care about their clear upset or he was promptly ignoring it.

"Want to watch it? I don't mind!" Yasuo nonchalantly gestured for them to sit down in the chairs. "I always love seeing the reaction on young couples' faces to their vows."

Neither Izuku nor Katsuki replied.

Vows? They had fucking *vows*?

Izuku was the first to take a seat. He eased into the rickety chair that leaned with his weight. He wearily looked down at the legs on the wooden chair that were bending ever so slightly with splinters poking out. Katsuki huffed heavily through his nose and did the same. The chair he sat in squeezed his large frame tightly and he could feel a dip that he shouldn't have in a chair made of solid wood.

Yasuo practically skipped over to his large, flat screen TV. It was sorely out of place, too luxe and shiny for such a rundown business. The sadistic owner popped the disc in, and thinly smiled while twirling his mustache. Yasuo propped himself against his desk and crossed his arms with the remote in his hand. The DVD began to play, and it was crystal fucking clear.

Great. We get to see this shit in high definition, Katsuki thought sourly.

Him and Izuku watched in shocked silence as their drunk selves stumbled on the screen hand in hand. The camera focused in and out with shitty handling—even shook a bit. It zoomed in on him and Izuku diving through the brown trunk of costume attire.

It was like gazing into some alternate reality with the way they were getting along fucking perfectly.

He and Izuku's hands were tightly woven together, rebalancing like perfect halves whenever the other wobbled. Izuku picked out a red bowtie and Katsuki picked out a green one. They pointed to the shoddy bowties, then to their shining wedding rings and snickered like something was funny. Both of them were too drunk to tie properly—but neither of them seemed to give a shit as they laughed. Then Izuku grabbed for a white wedding veil and giggled slightly as he toyed with it before donning it on himself like a crown.

"Do I look pretty?" The Izuku on the screen slurred through his drunken speech.

Katsuki watched himself on the television nod like an eager fool. "The fucking prettiest."

They walked up hand in hand towards the aisle with a man who was dressed in black slacks. The bastard didn't even have a formal top on—just some blue and purple Hawaiian print

shirt. Cheap wedding music played from up above and Katsuki could identify the tune as the cliché ‘Here Comes the Bride’ melody. He groaned out loud, unable to hold back his cringe.

Katsuki and Izuku watched themselves stand in front of the Civil Officiant holding hands. They looked like two kids playing dress up who didn’t know what they were doing. It was familiar, just like when they would play make believe in that tattered abandoned church. He watched themselves sign a bunch of disclaimers and waivers right before the Civil Officiant started reciting whatever magical words had sealed their fates.

Katsuki couldn’t bear to listen to it—he zoned it out and placed his pounding head in his hands. His racing thoughts tuned out whatever the fuck was being said on the screen.

This was a disaster.

This was quite possibly the biggest shit show he possibly had ever been in.

How would they even tackle this? Would they immediately get a divorce? Was that even fucking allowed right away? They weren’t supposed to see each other ever again after they executed Moore soon—but this was a whole different fucking mess. They couldn’t even extend the goddamn assignment if they wanted to because of that stupid police-raid.

As Katsuki’s thoughts were spiraling further down a black hole, suddenly they stopped. The sound of his own voice tugged him back to the surface.

It was him—but it didn’t *sound* like him.

Katsuki furrowed his brows and returned his eyes back to the screen. Standing there was himself in that crooked bowtie in his all-black clothing. He was holding Izuku’s hands and looking into his eyes like no one else was in the room.

But what threw him off the most was his voice.

His gruff voice was dripping in a tenderness that he’d never used with anyone.

“I promise to always come back to you, darling,” the Katsuki on the screen said seriously. He gripped Izuku’s hands tightly in his and slightly wobbled with a plastered grin. “I’ll find my way back to you, again and again and again. I promise to always be by your side and I’ll fucking kill anyone who gets in the way of us.”

The officiant gave Katsuki a weary glance at the casual mention of murder.

Izuku on the other hand was staring at Katsuki like he had recited a love poem. Big, green eyes were sparkling with hope and Izuku leaned into Katsuki’s touch with a sweet smile.

“And I promise to always come back to you too,” Izuku proclaimed. “I’ll always find my way back to you.”

“Promise?” Katsuki watched himself whisper desperately.

The drunk, unfocused gaze in his eyes sobered for a split moment.

The universe slowed as they held each other closer, translating words that were failing between them. There was a thoughtful pause as he and Izuku stared into each other's eyes with unfiltered rawness. Hurt. Relief. Joy. It was strange. Such an emotional expression was one Katsuki never imagined he could make. He had assumed that part of him was broken and rusted away.

Katsuki examined how his eyes were soft and adoring. He wasn't frowning. All his facial muscles were relaxed in a way that he forgot he could do. His gaze was half lidded, weighed down with heavy emotions as he caressed Izuku's skin with his rough fingers. He was holding onto the smaller hands in his like Izuku was his lifeline in the rocky ocean.

If Katsuki had to imagine what an expression of love looked like, this would be it.

"I promise, Kacchan." Izuku stared back at him with equal gentleness. "I missed you. I'm so happy we found each other again just like we said we would."

Katsuki wearily glanced towards Izuku next to him, who stared at the screen with an unreadable face. His hands were clasped together, and his face was void, entirely opposite as it was on the screen. Distant, unfocused green eyes gazed at the two of them holding hands. However, despite the emotionless mask, tears gathered at the bottom of Izuku's eyes. It was mis-matched, in a significant way.

He looked deeply sad.

"With that, do you, Bakugou Katsuki, take Mamushi Izuku to be your lawfully wedded husband?" The officiant on screen asked. He glanced between the two men like he was witnessing something pure.

"I do," the Katsuki on screen said.

The officiant turned to Izuku with a smile. "And do you, Mamushi Izuku, take Bakugou Katsuki to be your lawfully wedded husband in return?"

"Of course, I do," Izuku laughed lightheartedly. "Kacchan has always been my husband."

"Then I now pronounce you Bakugou Katsuki and Bakugou Izuku!" The officiant said happily.

Katsuki grimaced in anticipated horror and watched himself lean in to kiss Izuku. He imagined that they would share a sloppy, desperate kiss. Clumsy, drunk, and possibly cringe.

However, when their lips met, it was nothing like he'd ever witnessed.

He kissed Izuku like he was made of fragile memories and caressed his cheek like he was touching him for the first time. It was a delicate, majestic kiss. Soft in a way that Katsuki never thought he could be. Izuku's eyes fluttered shut, and he gingerly tilted his head to let Katsuki kiss him deeply. Izuku threaded his fingers carefully through his hair, letting himself be stirred through the kiss in a trusting manner. Almost like a ship allowing itself to be carried off by the current of the sea.

An unannounced thump banged on Katsuki's ribcage as he watched.

He was unsure if this was better or worse than a sloppy kiss.

He knew how to react to a raunchy kiss. Flinch, wince, and turn away. Curse under his breath and wave his hand dismissively. They could have easily brushed off this matrimony as a drunk decision if the kiss had been that. But *this*—this was not that.

There was something simmering beneath the surface between him and Izuku. It was excruciatingly obvious with how they handled each other, even while drunk out of their minds. Whatever it was—desire, pining, or just plain need—it was starved. It was utterly raw, ravenous and desperate to be fed. Their kiss was feeding into it, and that hunger threatened to consume them whole as he watched them inhale the other's essence like they needed it for survival.

Katsuki stared on, curious in the worst way, as he observed himself be gentler than he knew he was capable of.

He tore his eyes away from the screen to glance down at his hands in his lap. He saw the usual vivid flashes of caked up invisible blood sitting against his finger pads. He could perfectly envision all the vermillion violence he assumed his hands were made for. Then he gazed back at the screen. He didn't see all the violent years there as he held Izuku like he was precious.

At that moment, he could have been fooled.

His hands appeared like they were crafted for holding Izuku.

Then the single, lone witness to their drunk marriage clapped their hands on screen. That witness came forward and it turned out to be the owner of the Marriage Drive Thru. Yasuo was giddy, beyond happy and he was staring at them with an amused grin.

"Man, I love young love!" Yasuo announced. In the next split second, his friendly expression fell to flatness. He held out his hand and made a 'give it to me' motion. "That'll be 6,958 yen. For the marriage license fee."

Katsuki and Izuku broke from the kiss. Both of them took in new breaths—as *husbands*.

Katsuki studied how they affectionately stared at each other. Smiles gradually bloomed as they held each other's faces within their palms. The way Izuku was gazing upon him was familiar. It was nearly identical to the expression Izuku had given him that day in the nook so many years ago. Hopeful, naive, but most of all affectionate. Izuku appeared as though he didn't want to be anywhere else as they looked at each other as newlyweds.

Then, Katsuki watched himself fork over the yen without hesitation. He didn't even bother to look as he took the money out of his wallet and handed it to the owner. The entire time he kept his eyes trained on Izuku.

The owner of the business grinned in greedy delight. Yasuo counted the cash and pocketed it without a moment's hesitation.

"You'll find the official marriage certificate in the front!" Yasuo said. "Congratulations you two!"

"Now let's go have our honeymoon, darling—I've been thinking about nailing that ass of yours for eight years," was the last thing that could be heard as the video cut off.

Both Izuku and Katsuki sat there, speechless.

For an unknown reason, Katsuki was waiting for a post credits scene. He prayed for something to pop up on the blank screen that said 'gotcha!'. Katsuki even waited for Ashton Kutcher to stroll out and announce that this was the opener to the tenth season of 'Punk'd', in a surprise comeback for his career. However, none of that came. The screen remained black and blank as the information sank in through their pores.

Izuku was his goddamn husband by *law*.

He could hear Aizawa's voice in his head and feel his foot down his throat, "I told you to *kill* him not fucking *marry* him, Bakugou!"

"How soon can we get a divorce?" Katsuki asked.

He pushed down that strange fluttering feeling and didn't bother looking at Izuku next to him. He didn't even know if he *could* as he thought about how obscenely soft he had been with the man while drunk.

Yasuo looked at him in shock. "*A divorce*? So soon?"

"Yes," Katsuki hissed through gritted teeth. He frowned and the chair underneath him creaked loudly when he leaned forward. "Clearly, we were wasted beyond belief. There has to be some type of fucking law that prohibits intoxicated people from valid marriages. Nullify this shit or whatever."

"Sorry, no can do. This is a marriage drive thru, not a divorce drive thru. You're going to have to take that up with the government offices."

Katsuki's nostrils flared in irritation. He pushed down his anger as he glared at the man in front of them.

"And just *how* damn long would that take?"

"At least a month or so. Things get tricky with separations."

Katsuki balked. A *month*? He needed to be gone *tomorrow* and start his new fucking life. Suddenly he understood the analogy of marriage functioning like a ball and chain.

"There's no other way to get this figured out right *now*?" Katsuki pressed.

“I’m afraid not.” Yasuo offered them a false, sympathetic smile. “You can file a motion with the city of Nago if you would like. But you have to be patient. Divorces usually take a while, even for accidental marriages.”

“Why the fuck is it so easy to get married but hard to get divorced?” Katsuki grumbled under his breath.

Yasuo shrugged lackadaisically. He clearly didn’t give a shit about their situation. He’d probably done this a lot, scamming folks into getting hitched while drunk out of their damn minds and reaped the benefits. A man who preyed upon the vulnerable like this was scum in Katsuki’s eyes. If he had been given an order to kill him he’d do it in a heartbeat without batting an eye.

Silence washed over the room as the full situation pieced together. The man pulled the DVD out of the player attached to the TV and neatly tucked it away in a disc covering.

The clicking and turning of the multiple fans vibrated the air. Katsuki could feel the accumulation of perspiration on his skin. He wiped his brow, and his hand was unsteady. He then realized Izuku was unsettlingly quiet. His new husband hadn’t said a word since that tape played. He turned to Izuku in that moment, expecting to see a pissed off expression—or even a distressed one. But Izuku was neither.

Izuku was still staring at the blank screen, as though it was still playing. His eyes were distant, zoned out like his mind was trapped elsewhere.

“Well, here you two go,” Yasuo said as he handed them the DVD copy of their vows. There was a light push in his voice, signaling that he wanted them to leave as soon as possible. “It was so lovely meeting you two, but I have some business of mine to tend to before we open again.”

Katsuki sucked at his teeth. He hesitantly grabbed the DVD disc that was in a cheap plastic cover. It was light but heavy all at once. A walking contradiction just like he and Izuku were.

Izuku pursed his lips but didn’t look at him.

☽ ☽ ☽

They walked out of the Marriage Drive Thru with an anomalous feeling. It was nearly strangling him as he thought about their predicament. They had actually gotten fucking married—just like when they were kids.

That vision of younger Izuku and older Izuku started blending together a bit better than they had yesterday. Seeing the Izuku on that tape smiling was dangerous. He looked as though he still cared for him deeply, or at least seemed to. Young Izuku and older Izuku melted together slightly but were still playing tug of war in Katsuki’s mind. It hurt his heart, unsuspectingly.

They began walking out of the carnival in silence, side by side. Izuku’s eyes were glued down at the cracks in the sidewalk and Katsuki was looking at the DVD in his hands.

“We have to, uh, destroy that,” Izuku said, finally speaking his first words since the DVD played. “It has our legal names on it. It could be incriminating if we don’t get rid of it.”

Katsuki nodded. He had already planned on that, but there was a heaviness in Izuku’s suggestion that sounded like he was dragging the words. He curiously thought of Izuku’s surname. Or technically, his bachelor name now: Mamushi. It was fitting when Katsuki considered how venom green his eyes and hair were.

“So, when do you have time to figure this shit out with me?” Katsuki asked, addressing the obvious elephant in the room. “Do you have some down time after completing the assignment tomorrow to get this sorted out?”

Izuku worked his jaw. He anxiously looked up at him.

“I—I’m not sure. I was supposed to report back to headquarters directly after I finished the assignment. I usually get sent on back-to-back assignments, there’s not much leeway but I can try my best.”

“And where is headquarters or home for you?”

Izuku wearily assessed him. His eyes were sharp with a defensive edge—the same one the first time Katsuki had asked this question nearly a week ago.

“Only so I can know if you’re far from me or not, Izuku,” Katsuki amended in an attempt to alleviate the defensiveness. “My company’s headquarters is in downtown Yokohama. But after this assignment, I’m moving to the countryside of Hokkaidō—and I don’t plan on coming back. If we can get this sorted before that, it would be preferred.”

Izuku’s eyes softened. He twisted his fingers in a nervous tick.

“My headquarters are in Shinjuku, Tokyo. I live there as well.”

That was much closer than Katsuki assumed it would be.

He guessed Izuku had always been close this whole time.

“Good, we won’t have to travel some crazy amount.” Katsuki nodded. “I have free time after this assignment to get everything together and fill out my retirement papers and such. You know, disclaimers, NDAs, getting threatened to never speak about the ten years of homicide. The usual. Are you free to meet after this?”

“Um. Probably not. If I’m being honest.” Izuku glanced down to their feet. “I could call in some favors, but it would ultimately be risky. But I can mail copies of whatever you might need to file for the divorce if you give me your address. I think that would be the best route versus waiting for a meet up if you’re pressed for time. I’m barely at my apartment.”

“Okay. You can mail me the items I’ll need for you. It’s best to get this settled sooner rather than later.”

“Right. It’ll be like this never happened.”

The disappointment in Izuku's voice was potent.

They continued walking down the street without another word. The morning sun was growing hotter as it rose up into the sky. The sky lit up a bright blue and several fluffy white clouds passed by overhead, giving some shade with the swaying palm trees. More people were spilling out the various buildings with lighthearted chatter and coffee cups in their hands.

As they walked back to the hotel side by side, uncomfortable silence washed over them.

Why does this feel…off?

Something inside of Katsuki's core creaked with unease. Even though this marriage was clearly accidental, discussing getting a divorce was uncomfortable. Maybe it was their history. Or maybe it was the fact Katsuki still felt like they needed more time. Talking about the divorce almost felt taboo, like they were severing something that tied them with a dull knife.

As they were nearing the hotel, a familiar laugh caught Katsuki's attention.

He turned his head sharply to see Inasa and Shouto walking hand in hand, looking as though they were on a casual stroll. Neither of the undercover detectives seemed to spot him or Izuku as they walked around some back-alley corner. There was a strangeness about the way their body language was tense that made Katsuki's instincts flare.

Katsuki glanced at Izuku who seemed to be on the same page with him. Izuku looked up at him with a serious expression and jutted his chin towards the two men.

Wordlessly, Katsuki and Izuku shifted their walking to a loose follow behind Inasa and Shouto discreetly. They trailed until they found themselves weaving in and out of winding streets and in a lesser populated area. The two cops shuffled behind a building and let out sighs and pulled out their cell phones.

Izuku and Katsuki crouched behind a wall out of sight but directly within earshot.

"I got a message from the station," Shouto said quietly. Katsuki shifted his head slightly, straining to hear him. "My dad just told me the raid team will get to Ie Island around 12:00 sharp. They're going to attempt to apprehend Moore immediately. We got intel that Moore's going to be at the White Dove headquarters starting at 00:00 to begin prepping another trafficking deal for that afternoon. We'll catch him red handed. Are you ready?"

"I'm fully prepared," Inasa answered. His voice was equally as quiet. "I did more background research last night, and he's far more dangerous than I thought. His smiley demeanor is off putting compared to the grotesque things he's done in his life. It'll be nice to see him behind bars."

"I have to say though, I'm a little sad," Shouto said. There was a small sigh. "This case has been oddly relaxing with the camping and having a nice hotel room to ourselves. I'll miss it here a lot."

“We can always come back here and vacation, Sho. That won’t ever be an issue. We can basically do a second honeymoon here if you want to.”

“That’s very true.” Katsuki couldn’t see, but he could hear the smile in Shouto’s voice. “A second honeymoon sounds wonderful. Well. In the meantime, want to take a walk along the beach? We should probably go back to the hotel and rest up and prepare but let's soak up the view before we get serious.”

“Sounds like a great plan.”

The two detectives shuffled towards them, and Katsuki and Izuku immediately ducked out of sight.

As Katsuki held his breath, an inkling of jealousy wrapped around him. It trickled in slowly as he digested their words. He didn’t understand why—but he was envious of them. They had all the time in the world to address their problems and come back while he and Izuku were sorely pressed for time—because of them. It was unfair.

Shouto and Inasa disappeared out of sight steadily, talking about their dog at home. When Katsuki could no longer distinguish their footsteps, he stood up straight. Izuku did too and now the silence lingering between them was even more apprehensive.

Katsuki looked down at his watch that read 11:04. They had little more than twenty-four hours to kill Moore. As he stared at the numbers, the minute ticked up and 11:05 flashed on his watch. That small action made his heart clench.

He could practically feel time sliding between his fingers.

He couldn’t catch it even if he wanted to.

☽ ☽ ☽

When they arrived back at the hotel it was tense in a way Katsuki couldn’t name.

They had the rest of the day but somehow it felt like they had no time. The marriage was looming over their head, and they hadn’t spoken a word about it—or addressed how their inebriated selves even *thought* it was a good idea to get married.

They settled into the room and immediately Izuku started rummaging through his suitcase. He unlocked the bottom of his luggage to unveil a secret bottom compartment. It popped up to reveal a small briefcase. It was sleek, compact and contained an embossed logo: a ‘V’ being encircled by two snakes. Katsuki immediately recognized the symbol as the one that was on Izuku’s red folder that he had been shown.

Izuku lifted the briefcase up on the wooden table and clicked it open with some magic code. It popped open and revealed that it was lined with deadly knives, small handguns, and tiny vials of clear liquid with biohazard signs on them.

Izuku’s expression was unmistakably reluctant as he stared at the weapons.

Katsuki wandered over to his own suitcase that was directly next to Izuku's. He did the exact same thing. He lifted up his own weapon's briefcase and placed it across from Izuku's on the table. While Izuku's was matte, Katsuki's was leather with silver buckled and passed as unsuspecting. Katsuki popped it open and got to work immediately. Izuku followed suit.

Strangely, the quiet side-by-side preparation was relaxing.

Katsuki started clicking together pieces of his guns and counting the bullets meticulously. He knew how many shots he had and how many reloads as well. He was good at counting his bullets in the heat of exchanges. He never made the mistake of clicking a trigger only to be met with an empty barrel—it wasted time. If he were to run out of bullets, he had his blade.

He grabbed for the weapon in question and took a moment to examine its darkness and lethality. The black stainless-steel material was still shiny, proving to be high quality after all the throats it had slit. It nearly glittered while reflecting his mirror image—but the red eyes that looked back at him weren't the soft ones he had seen on that wedding tape. They were the hardened eyes of The Scarlet Killer.

This was familiar. This is what he was used to. He read his mother's name that was engraved in the handle and his own that was choppily carved on the other side.

While thinking about Moore, he experimentally tossed the hilt of it between his hands, testing the weight after being so long without the weapon.

Izuku stole a glance at him as he did this.

The freckled hitman blushed and rubbed his nape. Izuku was prepping his knives and guns too. But he also took the time to carefully load the various biohazardous liquids into tiny, color-coded syringes. Green. Red. Yellow. Katsuki caught sight of one vial that was labeled 'Tetrodotoxin'. Izuku loaded that one into the yellow syringe.

They continued like this. Silent, awkward and probably halfway thinking about vicious murder.

When the silence never broke, Katsuki decided to take the leap.

"Do you want to talk about what happened on that tape?" Katsuki finally asked. He sat down his blade after methodically sharpening it and looked up across the table at Izuku.

"Only that I'm sorry for getting drunk and suggesting that we get married," Izuku said quietly. He took out his knives and a sharpener and started carefully sharpening them in front of Katsuki. "I shouldn't have drunk so much, I should've cut myself off. I'm never that irresponsible on assignments usually—you probably hate me even more right now."

Katsuki let out a quick, sharp laugh. "Surprisingly, I don't think I hate you."

Izuku stopped sharpening his knife for a moment. His brows furrowed.

"You don't?"

“Naw, I don’t think I do,” Katsuki reaffirmed. He shrugged as he began to load the bullets in his favorite handgun. “Don’t get me wrong, you’re still a little shit. But I’m glad we found each other again after Tokyo. Even before I knew it was you, I don’t think I entirely hated you. I wanted to but I don’t think I ever did. You were annoying and aggravating but—I didn’t *hate* you. Besides, we *both* decided to get married. I signed that shit just as much as you did. We both fucked up, it’s a shared responsibility.”

Izuku’s expression grew gentle. “If I didn’t know better, I would say you’re getting soft on me.”

“Don’t fucking push it,” Katsuki scoffed. He narrowed his eyes with a deep frown. “I said I don’t hate you, doesn’t mean I’ve forgotten eight years of flopped assignments because you shoved your gun in my goddamn face.”

Izuku laughed lightly and resumed sharpening his blade. He eventually sat down in one of the chairs as he began prepping his weapons.

Katsuki decided at that moment, he wanted to be close to Izuku.

He took the chair that was stationed on the other side of the table and moved it directly next to Izuku. Green eyes looked at him curiously, but Katsuki acted like it was casual as he shuffled all his gear over. They faced each other, feet knocking slightly as they loaded and sharpened each and every one of their weapons.

Eventually, Katsuki took out his company laptop and he worked on hacking through systems to get blueprints of the headquarters on Ie Island. He poured himself a small glass of whiskey to give himself a little relaxation. Several hours passed until he was able to achieve the layout of the building, but when he did, he could see Izuku was impressed.

They made their strategy plan to hit the headquarters around 02:00 and slaughter Moore and Koizumi. They were still sticking to their plan to stage a scene that looked like a trafficking deal gone bad with a murder-suicide. The entire time while they planned, Katsuki could see Izuku stealing quick little glances at him. They were shy, observant but also it felt like Izuku was trying his best to memorize him before they parted ways.

Katsuki did the same—but a lot less shy about it.

He let his eyes linger on Izuku’s face, soaking up the multitude of freckles that decorated his skin. He knew this would be his last time seeing this doll face. While he rejoiced about that fact six days ago—he wasn’t so sure he was happy about it now.

When he started counting the shades of Izuku’s freckles a third time, Izuku finally caught his eyes with his.

Big, gorgeous green eyes were looking upon him with pure intent. Izuku offered a small, genuine smile.

“I’m happy I got to spend this week with you, Katsuki,” Izuku confessed quietly. He finished sharpening his last knife and placed it neatly in line with the others on the table. “It was nice

getting to know you. As both Katsuki and Kacchan."

Katsuki couldn't stop the smile that found its way on his face.

"I'm glad I could spend this week with you as well." Katsuki cocked his last gun and set it aside on the table. He leaned in slightly, locking their feet a tad bit more. "Weird how that all worked out, huh? Can't believe I'm a little disappointed this is our last night together."

"Actually—" Izuku nervously fiddled with his fingers while looking him up and down. "Before things get serious, do you want to relax a bit with a game? We have a couple more hours."

"Sure, I like games." Katsuki shrugged. He set the alarm on his phone for 01:00.

He tilted his head at Izuku when he could see green eyes flicker to different places on his figure: his eyes, his arms, his jawline then finally they settled on his mouth. There was a clear, underlying desire stirring in Izuku and a smirk slowly twitched on Katsuki's face. That marriage issue wasn't going to be resolved right now. Plus, they only had one more night left. Why not make the most of it?

"What game were you thinking of?" Katsuki asked in a deliberate low voice.

Izuku's throat bobbed like he was thirsty. Izuku then fluidly stood up from his seat and walked over to his bag. He reached into a small compartment before pulling out a deck of cards. He held it up for Katsuki to see as he sauntered back over to the table.

"Poker. Do you know how to play?" Izuku asked as he sat back down in the chair. He gently sat the deck of cards on the table next to their weapons.

Based on how Izuku was looking at him, Katsuki didn't think that's what he was going to ask.

With a curious stare, Katsuki leaned backwards and raised a neatly plucked eyebrow.

"Of course," Katsuki answered and folded his arms. "But I don't have any money to wager you. You're not going to drain me of my cash right before we have to part ways."

Deep green eyes locked on him with a mild challenge. The eye contact conjured up a spike of heat in the atmosphere. Izuku silently tilted his head and raked his gaze up and down Katsuki's figure. There was a pause as though Izuku was contemplating something serious as he bit his lip.

"The wager could be different pieces of our outfits," Izuku said finally.

At that, Katsuki grinned fiendishly.

He was a little taken back by the sudden boldness, but he fucking drank it in. It was undeniably delicious that hopeless romantic Izuku was clearly lusting after him as much as he was lusting for him too.

Katsuki bit his lip, leaned in and rested his elbows on his knees. His smirk turned feral when he saw Izuku's eyes dilate fully, and his thighs squeeze together. There was a small hitch in Izuku's shallow breath as he assessed Katsuki with a lust-stricken gaze.

"So, you want to play strip poker?" Katsuki clarified.

Izuku nervously nodded but didn't back down.

Katsuki deeply chuckled and rested his chin on top of his fist. He gave a cocksure grin as he ran his gaze from Izuku's lips all the way down to his thighs. He let his eyes sit directly on the slowly forming bulge in Izuku's shorts.

"There are easier ways to get me naked," Katsuki suggested. He snapped his eyes back up to Izuku's. "Isn't that what you want, to get me out of my clothes?"

"Yes." Izuku swallowed thickly like he was forcing down the last bit of his shyness. He sat back down, digging his intense stare directly into Katsuki's. "Don't you want me out of mine too?"

Katsuki chuckled. "More than you know."

"Then let's play."

Katsuki watched with growing interest as Izuku's eyes darkened.

Izuku leaned back and took the cards out the deck. Katsuki kept his smirk pointed as he leaned back too. He carefully picked up his whiskey, swirled it and started to steadily sip on it as Izuku began dealing out their hands.

Katsuki soaked in Izuku's body language at that moment. The other man was bouncing his leg slightly—out of nerves or excitement Katsuki wasn't quite sure. Maybe it was both. Izuku's eyes were dilated to green rimmed eclipses and his pink blush made him look beautifully flushed.

There were quicker ways to do this—he knew that. He could stand up and throw Izuku on that dumb heart shaped bed and simply undress him. But he'd play along with Izuku's game if it's what the other man wanted. Maybe he was still shy and if this helped ease him into it, then Katsuki would play whatever game he wanted. Katsuki swallowed another burning gulp of drink and picked up his hand.

"What's your ante?" Izuku asked softly. "We can pick which clothes go for the other."

"In that case, I choose that pretty little scarf around your neck," Katsuki said coquettishly. He grinned wickedly while pointing to the satin cloth. "I haven't been able to see my handy work all day. And yours?"

"Your shirt," Izuku said timidly. He laid out the cards on the table for their game.

"Going straight for the big thing huh?"

“Of course.”

He enjoyed the way Izuku smiled at him.

They started the game, playing prudently and Katsuki was examining his hand thoughtfully. He glanced down at the set in front of him and realized he easily could win this round. But he was more interested in seeing Izuku’s eyes on him. He purposefully threw the round and Izuku perked up with more interest. Katsuki stood up, looming over Izuku.

With a seductive grin Katsuki started undoing his black shirt. With every snap of each button, he knew he had every last ounce of Izuku’s attention. Green eyes fluidly trailed down until Katsuki undid the last one. He shrugged off the piece of clothing with a roll of his shoulders and it fell fluidly to the floor.

Izuku gripped the cards in his hand harder.

Katsuki played ignorant to the way Izuku was assessing him and massaged his fingers into his chest like he was working out a small muscle kink. He rolled his neck and flexed his arms casually before sitting back down in the chair. He rested his head against his fist and spread his legs wide. He could see Izuku get an eye full of the large bulge in his pants.

“Like what you see, darling?” Katsuki asked in a playful tone.

He adjusted himself in his pants purposefully and Izuku’s blush deepened.

“That’s a stupid question,” Izuku murmured. “You know I do. You just want your ego stroked.”

Katsuki’s grin widened, and he gripped his cock. “I want *way* more than my damn ego stroked.”

Izuku flipped over the next card with a deep lustful gaze.

The next round Katsuki won. Izuku rid himself of the scarf to give a full view of the mark on his pretty freckled neck. The small hint of fever in Katsuki sparked larger at the sight. His eyes dropped down to the sliver of chest that was showing on Izuku, and his mouth watered thinking about the other marks on Izuku’s skin.

The following rounds Katsuki purposefully lost. He liked watching Izuku squirm and wiggle with every piece of skin he showed. Even his goddamn ankles got a reaction out of Izuku—it was amazing. Slowly, Katsuki found himself losing his belt, his socks, then finally his pants.

When it came time to strip himself of his long baggy shorts, he stood up and unzipped directly in Izuku’s face. He did it slowly, enjoying the way Izuku was beginning to blush at the outline of his length with one less layer of clothing. He stepped out of the pants slowly and revealed the two black harnesses strapped to his upper thighs holding his guns.

“I didn’t realize you had strapped yourself today,” Izuku muttered. His eyes were distracted, flickering between Katsuki’s crotch and the weapons sitting comfortably on Katsuki’s muscular thighs.

“I’m always prepared, I told you that,” Katsuki answered easily. He tilted his head when Izuku licked his lips hungrily. Carefully, he reached out a hand and gently grabbed Izuku by the chin. He angled Izuku’s head up to get a visual of the blushing man. “You look like you like the sight.”

“I do,” Izuku whispered softly, sounding nearly hypnotized. “Steel looks good against your skin. It’s a nice contrast.”

At that comment, Katsuki was a bit surprised.

He took that singular thought and pocketed it away, noting to himself that Izuku liked the look of dark, steel against flesh. Katsuki sat back down, spreading his legs all the way. When the next round came he had the hand to beat out Izuku—but he purposefully lost again. He undid the straps around his thighs with a devilish grin and let the heavy metal drop to the ground hard enough to shake the surface.

Now he only had his underwear left.

“Are you throwing the game on purpose?” Izuku asked.

Katsuki gave a sharp chuckle and bit his lip.

“Is it that damn obvious?” He asked with a sly look. He glanced down to his nearly nude body that was covered in old scars. “I guess we have one more round until I lose completely. Unless your next ante is my earrings or my chain.”

Katsuki leaned against the table and his eyes darkened with heat as he stared at Izuku, giving the challenge. He hooked his thumb under his silver chain and pulled at it lightly to emphasize his point.

It was hard to contain his pure fucking excitement of the situation. Izuku was so goddamn timid, and he could tell he was going to have fun taking him apart.

Izuku stared back at him from over his hand of cards. His pretty blush was visible as he tried to hide his nerves. His leg was bouncing quicker as his eyes darted between Katsuki’s earrings and his underwear.

“Your boxers,” Izuku said confidently. “Your ante?”

Katsuki grinned like a wolf. “Your shorts.”

Izuku was barely looking at his eyes when he talked. He was drinking up Katsuki’s figure as he dealt out the next hand of cards. Katsuki could see how Izuku thought he was going to win the next round. But as Katsuki looked at Izuku’s shorts, he decided to flip the game around.

He showed his hand fully when it came time and Izuku’s face fell.

Katsuki had a royal flush.

The air shifted in that moment as Katsuki laid down his cards on the table. He stood up again and this time made a deliberate step towards Izuku. The other man didn't say anything, simply put his cards down as well. Katsuki could see Izuku's breathing shift, more shallow and sharper intakes.

Before Izuku could reach for his belt, Katsuki gracefully sank to his knees in front of Izuku. He reached forward, brushing his fingers with Izuku's warm ones. They fumbled a bit, silent exchange lingering.

Izuku slowly slid his hands away and parted his legs for Katsuki to move forward between them. Without breaking the heated eye contact, Katsuki delicately unbuckled Izuku's belt. He could feel Izuku shift in the seat as the belt was discarded to the ground. Then he looked down to the single two buttons sitting on Izuku's pants.

He popped each one slowly, giving Izuku time to back down. But he never did.

When he undid Izuku's shorts fully, Katsuki cursed under his breath in a groan.

"These are fucking beautiful," Katsuki whispered, mesmerized.

With his index finger, he lightly traced the top of the black lace that was exposed. It was soft to the touch, and it looked gorgeous against Izuku's skin. He snapped his eyes up to Izuku, who was biting his lip and staring down at where Katsuki was touching him. Katsuki took both of his hands and curled them under the hem of Izuku's shorts, ready to pull down if given the word.

But Izuku didn't say anything, just stared at him like he was in a vivid daydream.

"What are you thinking of?" Katsuki asked carefully. "I need you to say something, Izuku."

Silence, for a moment.

"I'm going to miss you more than I should," Izuku eventually confessed. He spoke in a hush whisper, as though scared to admit it out loud. "I'm going to miss you a lot, Katsuki."

Beautiful green eyes poured out unfiltered, heavy emotions. Izuku lifted a hand to caress Katsuki's cheek and there was a tenderness that took Katsuki off guard. It was soft to the point he nearly flinched at the implications.

Katsuki's heart fluttered against his will, and a bittersweet sensation overcame him. It tugged him down from being too in his own head, grounding him in the reality of the situation. It finally set in that this truly might be the last hours he had with Izuku. Katsuki gingerly placed a hand over Izuku's and curled his fingers around the smaller ones.

"Then let's make the most of these last few hours," Katsuki proposed. "Do you want this?"

"I do. I want to feel you so badly it hurts."

"Okay. Let's pretend for one more night."

Izuku nodded, solidifying the unspoken resolve lingering between them: they didn't have forever, but they had this one night.

Izuku lifted his hips when Katsuki tugged down his shorts in one swift motion, exposing the black lace underwear and tight holsters holding knives on Izuku's thighs. Emotions from an untraceable source ignited within Katsuki, burning him from his core. They all came tumbling down, crushing him underneath their invisible weight. Want, desperation, and even need came barging forward to fill his veins.

Izuku's hands threaded through soft, blond hair and he leaned down to kiss Katsuki with force.

The kiss stole Katsuki's breath and gave him it all at once.

It felt like someone had pushed life into his lungs for the first time. He thought he had known what it was like to kiss someone, but this was entirely a feeling he never experienced before. A tantalizing sparkle rippled through him, causing him to deepen the kiss with a fiery need he had never experienced. As they began to work their lips against each other, purely sweet intentions laced with desperate lust.

Katsuki kissed Izuku back fiercely, relishing in how soft the other man's lips were as he took control over the kiss. They pushed and pulled for a moment before Izuku conceded and Katsuki gripped the base of the thick, curly locks right above Izuku's nape and started guiding his motions. He stood slowly, not breaking the kiss as he loomed over Izuku and dragged his tongue along the soft bottom lip.

They broke apart for sweet air and it slammed into his lungs.

He felt different, nearly new.

Izuku was grasping onto his arms now, eyes looking up at him with an amount of adoration Katsuki didn't know was possible. They slipped into another kiss and this time he guided Izuku up and walked him over to the bed. They shuffled together, feet stumbling, and smiles intertwined with their sealed lips. The back of Izuku's knees knocked the edge of the bed, and he fell down with a gentle bounce.

Katsuki grinned as Izuku shuffled on the mattress, positioning himself in the center of the heart. He on the other hand walked over to his suitcase and pulled out the condom and lube he had tucked away. Izuku tilted his head, curious. Katsuki returned and he held up the two items for Izuku to see fully.

Izuku's blush was the cutest fucking thing Katsuki ever saw.

Katsuki climbed into the bed, a little too eagerly as he shifted towards Izuku. He couldn't help but stare for a moment. The other hitman looked stunning like this. Izuku's viridian eyes and curly hair against the deep crimson sheets evoked a heated sensation at the bottom of his stomach. With gentleness he didn't realize he had, Katsuki placed his hand on Izuku's chest, pushing him down against the flat surface of the bed.

Rhythmic pounding against his palm could be felt. His hand rested right above Izuku's heart.

Izuku curls sprayed across the pillows and his hands gripped the sheets. He spread his legs, welcoming Katsuki to come between them. They slotted together as Katsuki slowly undid the buttons on Izuku's shirt. He failed at holding back a curse when Izuku's chest was fully in view.

Hickies and freckles were littered everywhere but more eye-catching was the harness belt latched onto Izuku's torso. The leather was hugging him tightly, crisscrossed straps decorated in metal studs and sharp knives. Katsuki's eyes trailed the length of Izuku's body, loving how the harness belt matched the ones on Izuku's thighs and his lace panties.

Izuku made a move to unfasten the buckle on the torso harness but quickly Katsuki caught his wrist and stopped him.

"We'll keep these tonight," Katsuki said. He grinned wide and licked his lips slightly. "I like the look of your thighs decorated in knives. It's fucking incredible. I can't wait to watch them fucking quake with them on."

Izuku lightly shuddered. Katsuki moved to slide Izuku's shirt off his body completely, exposing him fully nude in nothing but the leather straps and black lace underwear. Now he had a full view of the panties that were holding Izuku's straining erection rather poorly. There was a small wet spot where the tip of Izuku's cock was, trying to break free.

Katsuki generously began to palm Izuku's erection, eliciting out the prettiest keen. He moved down fluidly, latching onto the small bruise that was painted across Izuku's perky nipple. He gave a gracious open mouthed kiss to the sensitive bud, swirling his tongue around it. He closed his eyes as he listened to Izuku sigh and moan when his tongue started swirling, licking, and flicking at the flesh. Izuku's body jolted with every action, sending warm flashes of pleasure all over his nerves.

"A-Ah, Katsuki," Izuku whispered, shakily.

"Feeling good?" Katsuki asked in a murmur against Izuku's warm skin. He pinched the other nub in his fingers, rolling it to make Izuku shake a bit.

"I-I am—I like it a lot." Izuku nodded shyly and arched himself into Katsuki's mouth. "Please, keep going. Can you play with them more?"

"How can I refuse when you ask so sweetly?"

Katsuki smirked and gave another long suck at the sensitive bud, relishing in the way Izuku quivered.

Izuku's shaky hands threaded through his hair once more when Katsuki switched to the neglected bud. He bit it lightly, drowning in the deep groan Izuku let spill into the air. The man underneath him bucked up until his hand, chasing the friction. Katsuki removed his hand and pressed his erection directly on Izuku's, grinding into him sensually while giving a gracious suck onto Izuku's flesh.

Izuku moaned so loudly and lewdly that Katsuki was sure someone heard it. He started grinding down on Izuku as he sucked, nipped and swirled his tongue across Izuku's chest. He traced his thumb across Izuku's bottom lip as he did this, taking in every second.

He pulled back, pulling Izuku's nipple a bit with him with his teeth. Izuku groaned and spasmed under him, wrapping his legs around Katsuki's waist. Katsuki let go of the sensitive skin and slowly began to trail kisses from Izuku's chest all the way up to his neck. He followed in his former self's footsteps, kissing directly on the hickies, darkening the spots a bit possessively when he thought about how this might be the last time he'd ever taste the freckled skin.

He gave a light kiss to the '217' tattoo on Izuku's skin.

They had sunk into another soul drowning kiss as Katsuki rolled his hips against Izuku's. He wrapped his arms around Izuku and cradled the back of his head as he traced his tongue into Izuku's mouth. They pulled apart and Katsuki slowed down a second. He looked at Izuku who was gazing at him softly.

His heart skipped a bit at the vulnerable expression Izuku was laying bare in front of him.

Katsuki wasn't quite sure he ever had this with another person he took to bed.

"What are you thinking about?" Izuku whispered.

"A lot," Katsuki honestly admitted. "I'm deciding how I want you—soft and deep or rough and hard. I can't decide."

"Do both," Izuku breathlessly whispered. His large doe eyes sweetly gazed up at Katsuki. "I want you to take me like you've been waiting for me your whole life—because we have. You're my Kacchan, my sweet Kacchan who I only dreamed about for years." There was a pause, and then Izuku's face twisted into a much less sweet expression, nearly dark. "But you're also my *Katsuki*." Izuku harshly said his name with a fierce bite.

Beautiful green eyes darkened even further as Izuku leaned in. He wrapped his hand around Katsuki's throat and pulled him down until their lips nearly touched as he continued to speak.

"You're my brute of a Katsuki who can hold a knife against my throat and a gun against my goddamn skull," Izuku hissed. Nails sank into Katsuki's throat, tacking tiny crescent moons. "So, fuck me like I'm your Izuku and your *darling*."

A thread inside of Katsuki snapped. The two versions of Izuku pieced together like a jigsaw falling in place. He gave a sharp laugh as it all blended into one because Izuku was fucking right. Izuku was *his* pain in the ass, but he was *his* savior and that was both a curse and a blessing he had to accept. Because at the end of the day, Izuku was his as much he was Izuku's.

Katsuki grinned ferally.

He lifted a hand to grip Izuku's jaw tenderly and tilted his head.

“You’re damn right,” Katsuki agreed in a low tone. His hand then squeezed until he heard Izuku hiss a bit in pain. “You are *my* darling, aren’t you? The little devil that I’ve been fighting with for years. I should fuck you like you deserve and *more*.”

With that, Katsuki threw all his overthinking to the wind.

They locked in another all-consuming kiss that was sharper, harsher and hungrier. Katsuki’s grip on Izuku’s jaw turned bruising as he kissed him deeper than before, biting and searching for the sparkle that had ignited. They broke apart with Katsuki biting the plump lip in between his teeth with a dark look.

Without missing a beat, Katsuki reached for the lube on the side of them.

“Get on your stomach, darling,” Katsuki said.

“My stomach?” Izuku looked confused.

“Yes, your stomach,” Katsuki said with a smirk. “I didn’t wait eight years to *not* eat your ass.”

At that, Izuku flushed but still obeyed. He rolled onto his belly and coyly spread his legs and slightly arched himself in anticipation.

“*Hah*.” Katsuki laughed a bit. “What a good obedient boy.”

Katsuki drank in the sight of the leather harness spreading across Izuku’s back in a lovely double diamond shape. His fingers curled around one of the harness straps and none too gently yanked Izuku into arching his back more. He leaned down against Izuku’s ear as he forced the man’s legs apart.

“What the hell did I tell you about making sure you’re arched well?” Katsuki reminded him in a low tone.

Izuku nodded and grasped for purchase, hugging one of the silk pillows in his arms as Katsuki began to shift down. He positioned himself behind Izuku, and he could feel his mouth water at the sight of the plump ass he’s waited fucking years for.

He took his calloused hands and began to massage Izuku’s ass, enjoying the softness mixed with muscle as Izuku buried his face into the pillow. Red ran down from the tip of Izuku’s ears to his shoulders as Katsuki spread apart Izuku’s cheeks, sliding the thin strap of the panties to the side with the motion.

He decided to not have mercy.

He went straight in, running his tongue against Izuku’s entrance, and Izuku jumped slightly at the sensation, but Katsuki snapped his hips down instantly as he probed his tongue against the fluttering hole. Izuku groaned as Katsuki licked, and lapped at his sensitive area, tenderly working it open.

Plush legs started to shake a bit and Katsuki made a hungry groan at the feeling of the tremors against him. He picked up, giving sweet kisses as he dug his fingers into Izuku's flesh more. When his tongue started to push in further, Katsuki realized just how damn sensitive Izuku was. He was whining like this was his first time being eaten out, and the shaking picked up to a steady rhythm.

Within the next minute, Izuku began twitching away from him like it was too much as he moaned loudly. But Katsuki wasn't having that. He tightened his grip on Izuku and yanked him back onto his tongue, making sure to push deeper and eat him out with each fuck into his hole.

"Fuck!" Izuku nearly screamed.

His breathing hitched into a delightful octave as Katsuki pushed his tongue in further, swirling and sucking. The vulgar sound of wetness echoed into the room as Katsuki's breathing picked up and Izuku's small tremble turned into an outright quake. Izuku was cursing and gripping the pillow so tightly Katsuki could've sworn he was going to tear it in two.

Then Katsuki heard something that shattered all his control.

"Ka—*Kacchan*," Izuku slurred into the pillow. It was faint, barely audible and it sounded like a cross between a plea and a moan. Then it happened again as Izuku fucked back on his tongue. "Kacchan, *please*."

Katsuki gave a long, flat tongue lick at Izuku's sensitive hole and heard that muffled cry of his nickname. His dick pulsed in his boxers harder than he thought it would.

He grabbed the lube and spread a generous amount on his fingers, massaging it until it was slightly warmer. He pressed his three fingers against Izuku's fluttering entrance and he could feel Izuku stiffen slightly.

Katsuki curiously considered the tenses in Izuku's muscles. He was nervous. It was radiating off of him in waves. Katsuki wordlessly switched three fingers to one. He decided to keep his tongue licking at Izuku's hole as he slowly slid in his finger. He eased some of Izuku's tenseness with his tongue, messaging the fluttering entrance gently with his wet appendage as he pushed in, knuckle deep. He groaned in his throat at how fucking *tight* Izuku was. His one finger was being perfectly hugged.

Izuku's tenseness eased a bit, but it didn't stop the flow of soft moans. Katsuki pumped his singular finger in and out, easing in more with each thrust as Izuku whimpered and shuttered. He probed a second finger at the tight entrance and Izuku automatically stiffened again. This time, Katsuki reached under and gripped Izuku's cock and began to pump it, twisting his wrist at the tip.

A throaty, ecstasy filled groan filled the room.

Katsuki slipped in the second finger at the same time he squeezed the tip of Izuku's cock. He smeared the dripple of precum that leaked out with his thumb as he looked for the one

particular spot. He fucked his fingers in and out until he curled them and Izuku jerked immediately with cry.

Katsuki could practically taste the rapture that spilled all throughout Izuku on his tongue. Izuku looked over his shoulder at Katsuki, blushing furiously, and his eyes were bleary. Katsuki curled his fingers again and was given the same reaction, but Izuku pushed back against him this time. With a steady rhythm, Katsuki began to abuse and pulse against that spot, forcing out a cacophony of groans, hisses, and moans from that pretty mouth.

“Have you ever had your prostate milked before, darling?” Katsuki asked, enthralled by the handsome look of bliss on Izuku’s face.

“N-No—*ah*!” Izuku attempted to answer as Katsuki pressed firmly against the sweet spot. He dropped his head and groaned loudly. His thighs shook and his knees tried to close but Katsuki kept them apart with a firm grip as he pressed and caressed Izuku’s spot.

“How does it feel?”

“It feels intimate?” Izuku said, unsure.

Katsuki snorted. “I mean does it feel good or bad. I sure as hell would *hope* it feels intimate when I’m two knuckles deep in you.”

“It feels good,” Izuku said again, moaning.

Katsuki grinned and picked up the pace, ramming his fingers at the right angle, curling and pulling more moans out of Izuku’s pretty, pink mouth. The echoes of ecstasy grew louder with every twist and pulse until Katsuki felt a delicious tremor. It was harsher than the rest and he decided he wanted to feel that again. He kept going, merciless and fever filled with every thrust. Izuku gasped in shock and tried to scramble for his wrist.

“Ka-Kacchan, w-wait, you’re going to make me cum—”

“—That’s the goal,” Katsuki quipped in a low, raspy voice. He didn’t stop his moments when Izuku’s hand tried to hold his wrist. “I need you pliant if you’re going to take me in.”

Within no time, a third then fourth finger was added and Izuku began shuddering and trembling harsher than before. Katsuki fucked them in and out with more purpose now, jolting Izuku frantically. With every beat, Izuku’s eyes fluttered closed until he went cross eyed. There was a splintering crack in Izuku’s voice and quakes harsher than before rolled all over Izuku’s beautiful body. The pulsing cock in Katsuki’s hand twitched as he twisted and squeezed the sensitive tip at the same time he pushed against Izuku’s prostate.

It was possibly the most majestic moment Katsuki had ever seen.

Izuku twisted his eyes shut, arched all the way against the four fingers inside of him and screamed out “*Kacchan*” in a gorgeous, high voice. He came into Katsuki’s hand harshly, jerking his whole body as spurts of cum poured out.

Izuku released a strangled groan as Katsuki hit his prostate several more times for good measure and then retracted his fingers. Katsuki moved both his hands away, looking at the slick lube that was drenching one and the hot cum that was pooled in the other. Izuku looked over his shoulder at him and Katsuki licked the cum off his palm while digging his heated gaze into Izuku. He lapped up every last drop, cleaning his hand thoroughly and swallowed all of Izuku's seed.

Izuku's eyes darkened with interest as he turned on his side to look at him better.

Katsuki slid off his boxers, kicking them off to some corner of the room as his cock dropped with weight on the bed. He tore the condom open with his teeth vigorously and slowly started to sleeve it over him. Izuku was biting his lip and looked at him wearily.

"Got something on your mind?" Katsuki asked when Izuku's stares became intense.

"You're big," Izuku said bluntly. "I, uh, thought you were but—" He licked his lips. "—You're bigger than I thought."

"Nine and a half, darling, and thick as a coke can," Katsuki said smugly. He lathered up the lube on his length, stroking it slowly and deliberately. "I'll make sure you feel every inch too. Don't worry."

He placed his hands on Izuku's back and held him down on his belly as he began to line himself up. Izuku tensed immediately at the feeling of the wet tip against his already spent hole. Katsuki could feel his muscles tighten under his palms. Slowly, Katsuki moved one hand to hold Izuku's.

Instantly, Izuku gripped back. He held his hand as he arched backwards, egging Katsuki on.

Katsuki moved slowly, working Izuku open with care.

He pressed in and the warm entrance felt like it sucked him in as well. Izuku buried his face in the pillow as Katsuki stretched him out slowly. The hot length eased with care into his tight body. Izuku was tight. *Really* tight, if Katsuki was being honest with himself—he was unsure if he had ever had someone hug him like this. The friction was unmatched and addictive as he sank inside, inch by inch.

Katsuki leaned his head down to Izuku's nape and planted soft kisses as he started to thrust with more purpose. Izuku had his hand gripped so tightly that Katsuki could see his knuckles turn white. When his cock was deep enough to reach Izuku's sweet point, Katsuki angled it just right and thrusted against it.

Instantly, Izuku moaned into the pillow. Katsuki thrusted again but was met with another muffled moan. He 'tsk'd slightly and reached a hand up to grip the base of Izuku's curls. He yanked Izuku's head backwards out of the pillow.

"Don't hide your fucking moans," Katsuki hissed. He reeled back and thrusted in again with more vigor and Izuku sharply choked on his desperate moan. "I want to hear every single pretty sound you make. I can tell you're holding back on them."

“Then *make* me *make* them,” Izuku said challengingly. “Make me scream.”

“Oh?” Katsuki asked, falsely coy.

He tilted his head in interest as he gripped the base of Izuku’s hair tighter. He none-too-kindly pulled Izuku up by his roots, ignoring the small protest. He forcefully craned Izuku’s neck backwards and bit the outer shell of his ear.

“Is that the game you want to play with me?” Katsuki warned. He traced his other hand along Izuku’s neck, feeling his adams’ apple bob with anticipation.

“And if it is?” Izuku questioned. “What are you going to do about it, *Katsuki*?”

Katsuki made his hand a necklace around Izuku’s throat and squeezed.

“I guess I have no other choice than to make you scream.”

In one foul swoop, Katsuki jerked both him and Izuku upright on their knees. Izuku gasped in surprise at the harsh handling on his throat as his back slammed against Katsuki’s chest and the cock inside of him buried to the hilt.

Katsuki fluidly changed his hand from choking Izuku to wrapping his whole arm around Izuku’s neck in a sleeper hold. He expertly squeezed, just enough pressure to be sadistically pleasureful and not enough to make the sweet man lose consciousness. Izuku reached up to grab onto his bicep and pushed back against him when Katsuki started a merciless, sharp rhythm.

Izuku cried out through the hold as he sank his fingers into Katsuki’s flesh. His was body helplessly fucked into as he was held in place. Soft green curls bounced, choked screams crackled in the air, trembling thighs quaked. Katsuki fucking loved the way Izuku’s eyes went crossed as he drove into him over and over again. Izuku felt fucking delicious. The tight hole was sucking him in, soft and wet. The slippery lube spilled down Izuku’s thighs as it wet Katsuki’s cock in delicious friction.

Katsuki groaned and gripped Izuku’s hair harder. He gave steady blows of deep, sensational thrusts, purposefully laying on unforgivingly to Izuku’s prostate until the other man quaked and arched with uncontrollable ecstasy.

“I could snap your neck like this,” Katsuki whispered cruelly. He tightened his hold around Izuku’s throat and gripped his hair to pull his head back. Izuku tried to groan but only gasped in sharp intakes. His face was red, colored in blissful ecstasy. Katsuki’s smirk spread as he pressed his lips against Izuku’s ear and murmured, “You’re so vulnerable right now—I’m surprised you trust me after all these years. But you’d probably let your *Kacchan* do anything to you, wouldn’t you?”

Izuku nodded and made a weak attempt to meet Katsuki’s thrusts.

“Fucking *pathetic*,” Katsuki spat. “You’re enjoying this aren’t you? Do you like getting choked out like a little fucking masochist?”

Izuku couldn't answer as Katsuki picked up the pace. He choked, dug his nails in further to Katsuki's biceps and quaked harshly as he attempted to keep up with the pounding rhythm. His body trembled against Katsuki, pushing back on the thick cock railing into him. White spots danced across his vision.

With a sharp, choked outcry Izuku came again. Ribbons of cum decorated the red sheets down below.

"Oh, you're *really* fucking enjoy it." Katsuki chuckled darkly. "I wish you could see your face, darling. You look so goddamn *sweet*, gasping for air and nearly in tears like a goddamn crybaby. Such a little cry baby for my cock." He fucked into Izuku harsher as his own orgasm built. "You're a goddamn dream, you have no idea. Look at how well your fucking *taking it*. Fuck. *Take it,* darling—take it *all*." He rolled his hips deeply, grounding inside of Izuku and eased up on the choke hold slightly.

Izuku sharply gasped for air as he tried to keep up with the pace of the cock splitting him open.

"M-More—give me more, please," Izuku begged, voice starved. "K-Kacchan, *please*. I need it—I need *you* so much."

"You're going to be the goddamn death of me," Katsuki harshly hissed. Beads of sweat rolled down his face.

He released Izuku, harshly pushing the man face down on the bed with deliberate, dominating force. He enjoyed the useless way Izuku's shaking legs couldn't hold him up and his arms were no better. Izuku could barely remain on all fours, and he eventually slumped forward with a groggily whine. Katsuki grabbed a hold of both straps on Izuku's harness and hoisted him up, holding him with his strength. Then he sharply yanked Izuku backwards on his cock, angling himself just right.

A sharp gasp of surprise echoed out from Izuku as he was pulled back on the large cock again. The warm tip hit directly against his sweet spot and made him cry out. Katsuki did it again and again, leveraging the harness to a full advantage, until he picked up a steady rhythm of fucking Izuku back on his pulsing length while holding up his weight.

"Is this what you wanted? *Hah*?" Katsuki demanded as he snapped his hips into Izuku's body. "I'm going to fucking wreck you at this rate. You'll barely be able to *think* soon."

He watched the way his cock drove in without a lick of mercy into the plush backside. The force he was using bounced Izuku's cheeks with every thrust, punching out captivating high-pitched moans from Izuku's whimpering mouth. The vulgar sounds of their skin slapping and the wetness of the lube squinching met his ears as he picked up the pace.

"—Kacchan, Kacchan*, Kacchan*," Izuku babbled with a hoarse voice.

His head bounced with the fervent motions; eyes shut as all the ecstasy rode throughout his body. He grabbed onto his own harness with his hands as he allowed himself to be roughly maneuvered, fucked back on the cock splitting him open. He attempted to form several more

incoherent words that contained syllables of Katsuki's name. Then Izuku whined wantonly and clenched, and his cock began to pulse.

Katsuki's nostrils flared as he gripped the leather straps harder.

He hoisted Izuku back with all his strength, reaching deep and going steadfast. Katsuki's groans started to grow steadily uneven as the current of rapture in his body began to coil tightly in his stomach. His toes curled as Izuku tightened around him, signaling that there was somehow a third orgasm on the way.

"F-Fuck," Katsuki harshly grunted. "You're going to milk me, darling."

Izuku hiccupped, and tears gathered on the edge of his eyes. He tightened further on the thick shaft as he was vigorously snapped back on it over and over.

Katsuki groaned deeply and gave several deep, needy thrusts into Izuku. Deliberately hitting the angle to make Izuku scream as his orgasm came rushing forward. It was pure ecstasy, and it lit all his nerves on fire. His vision went white, and his grip on the harness grew tighter as he came harder than he ever had in his life. Katsuki cursed loudly and snapped Izuku upright all the way as he buried himself to the hilt. Izuku's beautiful back arched with the tension in the hold as he buried himself all the way inside.

Katsuki groaned in his throat as his warm cum spilled into the condom and the delicious tight walls made sure to squeeze it all out of him.

Izuku gasped in sharply as he came a third time, untouched and dry. He sobbed instantly, voice raspy and fucked out. Katsuki could see from over Izuku's shoulder as Izuku cock spasm and a tiny bit of cum oozed out. In contrast, Izuku's whole body violently shook with unfathomable pleasure as his eyes screwed shut. His body clamped around the cock inside of him. His mouth hung open, letting a litany of whines loose and his brows were pinched together.

Katsuki wrapped his arms around Izuku, pulling him against his chest as the weeping man rode out the dry orgasm. Loud sobs wrecked through Izuku's throat as he leaned his head back on Katsuki for support.

"I got you, darling," Katsuki whispered. He tightened his grasp as Izuku gave one more full body tremor. "There you go, feel it all the way through you. You're doing *so* fucking good."

Katsuki kept going, offering up sweet nothings in Izuku's ear as the smaller man became doused in overstimulation. With gentle care, Katsuki lowered them on the mattress, and he slid out of Izuku with a wet pop. Izuku whined at the loss and Katsuki was slightly surprised to feel Izuku push back on him, but he wrote it off as instinct from being fucked out.

He carefully cradled Izuku in a spooning position until he finally came off his last wave.

Izuku's gasping slowly shifted to panting then finally labored, heavy breathing. They laid there, quiet. Katsuki planted a delicate kiss against Izuku's temple as he calmed down.

A gentle draft blew in from the open window, cooling them down. A small hand reached up and touched Katsuki's arm after a while. He loosened his hold a bit, letting Izuku shift around in his arms. There was a tiny spark of pride that flickered in Katsuki when he heard Izuku groan and winced. Pain was radiating up his backside, no doubt. There would be a limp there and Katsuki was a bit prouder than he should've been at that moment.

Izuku turned to him fully, blissful green eyes stared at him and Katsuki stared back.

"Katsu—" Izuku started and stopped. He touched his throat when his voice caught on the hoarseness. He cleared it a bit and smiled shyly at Katsuki.

"Give your throat a break," Katsuki chuckled. He touched Izuku's neck as well, giving a solid once over at his handy work. Pretty bruises, specifically an undoubtedly recognizable choking mark, were slowly beginning to form over the hickies. Katsuki's eyes darkened a bit. "You look fucking great like this."

Izuku hummed hoarsely. He leaned in and gave Katsuki a chaste kiss.

"You know," Izuku started, throat scratchy. "We technically consummated our marriage."

Katsuki scoffed and shook his head. He smirked, amused. "You're a fucking nerd."

☽ ☽ ☽

They laid there for a while, suspended in time. The intensity of the moment climbed down, and calmness settled into the air all around them.

Katsuki realized he could indulge in this for much longer than the time they had. He did his best not to look at the clock, waiting for whenever the blaring alarm he had set decided to go off. He wanted to stay blissfully ignorant in this moment with Izuku, and it seemed like Izuku wanted the same.

Everything stilled as they laid there in each other's hold. He had his arm wrapped around Izuku's shoulders, drawing him in close as Izuku leaned his head against his chest. Izuku's voice returned after a while, and they found themselves chatting lightly. The bundle of burning questions inside of Katsuki fizzled away. He rationalized that he could spend the next few hours pressing down on questions about Izuku. There was still so much he didn't know. Or he could enjoy Izuku's smile.

He decided on Izuku's smile when the smaller man leaned into him affectionately.

Katsuki's heart clenched when he realized this was probably the closest he had come to feeling like someone cared for him. There were little touches that Katsuki knew were far inappropriate for them. Forehead kisses. Izuku brushed his hair behind his ear. Gentle caresses that should only be saved for lovers. *Real* lovers. Katsuki didn't know exactly when their facade slipped into the bed with them, but it did. It started to borderline feeling like they were simply two husbands having a post-coital cuddle. Izuku measured his hand against his playfully at a point, their matching rings glimmering in the soft moonlight together.

Katsuki realized they could take these off now—but neither of them said a word as they stared at their hands pressed together while cuddled into each other.

Katsuki then slowly curled his fingers, intertwining them with Izuku's.

Warm.

"Thank you," Katsuki whispered into the dark room. He stroked Izuku's freckled skin with his thumb, relishing in the softness he might never feel again. "I meant to tell you that earlier. Thank you for being there for me that year in Tokyo. It means a lot to me. You—" Katsuki sucked in a deep breath. "You saved me, when no one else was there."

Izuku smiled back at him, with a woeful nostalgia gleaming in his eyes.

He stared at Katsuki like he already missed him.

"You saved me too."

Chapter End Notes

Let me know if you have any questions, comments, screams or theories below! I love reading them so so much! You guys are a joy ^^

Thanks so much for reading!

Chapter 10: Vivace

Chapter Summary

> Vivace (tempo): Very Fast

Chapter Notes

> Hello! Welcome back to this very special chapter. Thank you to Luna for betaing 💜💜💜 She has my whole heart! Okay, enjoy the chapter!
>
> **Warnings: *taps the Graphic Depictions of violence and Dark Themes tags* These are fair game from here on out. Homicide (on screen). Disturbing descriptions and actions. Human trafficking.**

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 10 — Vivace

.

.

.

The color was dull in the room late at night.

The soft pastels were overshadowed with a tinge of grayness that looked as if someone had drained all the life from the atmosphere. It was currently the dead of night, and there was a sensation inside of Katsuki twisting and turning as he dressed in his gear alongside Izuku.

His stealth outfit consisted of midnight black material. Not the normal shade of black of his outfits, it was deeper, closer to spilled ink than anything. It absorbed all the light and masked him like he was a shadow of death.

His shirt covered his torso fully and it was taut against his body for mobility. Sitting on top was his sleek leather holster, holding his guns for quick draw. His pants were slightly baggy, to give room for his gear but were secured to his body by two straps on each leg. One hugging his thighs and another his calves. They had discreet leather pouches to hold his reloads.

He loaded up all his pants' cargo pockets with his various other items: mainly his bullets, his knife, and pain killers if it came down to it.

Katsuki thought about Koizumi's slimy face. He slid on brass knuckles over his leather gloves for good measure. He then carefully covered his face with a black gaiter mask and tucked his distinctive blond hair under a black hat.

Izuku dressed similarly but with slight differences.

Instead of black, Izuku's gear was deep, velvety green to the point it nearly blended with the darkness. It was only when he got up close did Katsuki realize the sheen of viridian it had.

It was a full body suit, clung tightly to his frame for maximum mobility with his leaner stature. His holster was now on the outside of his body along with the lethal number of knives and two guns pocketed on his torso's holsters. Donning his face was a black gaiter also and his suit had a large, hooded covering for his hair. Striking green eyes were the only things that could be seen in the dark attire.

However, what stood out the most to Katsuki, was the two twin daggers attached on either side of Izuku's hips.

They were in the shape of fangs. Long, silver and possessed ridges on the side where it curved inwards. On the bent outside, it was sharp enough to cut swiftly through calloused skin. It was a type of design crafted for causing agonizing pain on one side and quickly ending suffering on the other. The hilts had deep green tassels at the ends.

The way the tassels swayed with Izuku's walk was enticing.

For the most part, Katsuki had always seen Izuku at work in the daytime. Or when he was undercover. These were situations where Izuku needed casual gear to blend in so he could get close to marks. Now, that wasn't the case. Izuku was dressed to kill, nothing more. Seeing him like this was an entirely different feeling.

They packed up their luggage and wiped any evidence of themselves from the room. The only items they didn't pack were two compact black backpacks.

Their plan was straight forward: Get to Ie Island, kill Moore, and stage the scene to look like a twisted love affair gone wrong. Afterwards, they would change into hiking clothes and go to the hiking area on Ie Island. They would act as though they had been there, enjoying some early morning hiking when the police raid hit since there would be little time between killing Moore and checking out of the hotel for good.

Having a bullet proof alibi was needed. After the time for the police raid had finished, they would come back to the hotel, which would be in chaos from the raid. Everyone would no doubt be kicked out from the fiasco. They could inconspicuously grab their luggage from the room and leave with the rush of confused people, blending in like nothing had happened.

It could work—Katsuki believed it could. It had too.

He zipped up his bag, put it on his back and fastened the straps tightly.

“You got everything?” Izuku asked, slightly quiet.

Izuku slung his backpack over his shoulder as well. As he did this, he assessed Katsuki carefully. His eyes wandered all over as he chewed on his bottom lip.

“Yeah, I got everything,” Katsuki responded.

“You sure? Do you have your cell phone?”

“I’m sure.”

“What about the silencer for your handgun?”

Katsuki raised a brow at Izuku. “Yes. I’m positive.”

“Wh-What about your change of clothes. Did you pack the hiking gear?”

Katsuki frowned deeply. He was baffled by the sudden pestering—but when he turned to look at Izuku, it clicked.

Big, green eyes stared up at him and Izuku gave him a small, saccharine smile. It perfectly mirrored the way Izuku used to stare at him whenever he came to visit in Tokyo. The memory of how doting, careful, and attentive young Izuku was painted in his mind. He could still vividly feel that first shower in the church etched in his skin. Tiny hands carefully picking the dirt out of his hair and scrubbing away his tears. Smiling the entire time too.

His heart sung low when he realized what was happening.

Izuku then stepped forward and adjusted the backpack strap on his chest. Izuku’s hands were unsteady as he did this, shaking like an uneasy tide. Katsuki reached up to clasp a hand over them.

The trembling stopped.

Izuku looked at him, eyes wide like he was snapped out of a faraway memory. Katsuki pulled down both of their masks so they could see each other’s faces properly.

“You don’t have to take care of me anymore,” Katsuki whispered with unfiltered vulnerability. “You don’t have to worry about me anymore, alright? I can take care of myself.”

Izuku’s whole body clammed up.

The delicate, freckled face sparked with sudden shock, but slowly relaxed. Izuku soaked in the words, letting them trickle down in his chest and fill him with understanding.

“Okay,” Izuku whispered. He offered a bittersweet smile. His eyes watered slightly, shining with the tiny reflection of bright moonlight. He carefully retracted his hand. “No more

worrying."

Katsuki didn't quite know what to do with himself.

He felt like he was being split between dreary reality and the illusion of the pastel Paradise. The burn in his chest mimicked someone throwing a bucket of scathing hot water on him. All he wanted to do was scream out in pain from being so torn on the inside. But he couldn't.

He had to keep his emotions in check, especially now.

Izuku pulled up the mask over his face once more, and Katsuki decided to set aside his emotions until later. He could sort out all his mixed feelings *after* Moore had a bullet lodged in his skull.

Katsuki pulled up his mask too, and they both headed towards the balcony window. Izuku grabbed the long, black rope that was laying on the table as they headed out. They had decided to embark via balcony and drop down into the lush backyard of the hotel. This way they could avoid anyone on a nighttime stroll while they were in full gear.

As they carefully knotted the rope, Katsuki could see Izuku wince slightly when he made a sharp movement. Katsuki wearily looked at him. *Maybe* he should've taken it easier—

"Are you going to be okay?" Katsuki asked as Izuku threw the other end of the rope over the balcony. He looked down at Izuku's feet and noted how Izuku was discreetly pulling his weight off one side. "You're limping. If you need me to cover you, let me know."

"That won't be needed," Izuku said. "My backside stings a little, but I'm alright. Nothing I can't handle."

A pang of guilt echoed in Katsuki. "I should've tried to be gentler."

"You were perfect. I wouldn't change how it happened for anything. You're underestimating my ability to work through pain, and this is just a bit of discomfort."

Katsuki took Izuku's word for it. The man *was* deadlier than three hitmen from The Company combined.

They scaled down the building carefully with Katsuki going first. There was a small gap between the end of the rope and ground, forcing Katsuki to jump down onto the grass. He gave a light grunt but landed well. Next followed Izuku. Izuku landed swiftly, but a shock of pain radiated in his muscles. His eyes went wide, and a startled choke rattled in his throat as his knees gave out.

Katsuki held his breath when Izuku stumbled. The freckled man immediately fell over, but quickly caught himself by holding his hands outward for balance.

Izuku's face painted pink with embarrassment and Katsuki's twisted into a scowl.

"Not needed, my *ass*," Katsuki chastised. He yanked Izuku from the ground by his backpack and frowned. "I should've been fucking softer—"

“No,” Izuku shot down rapidly. He groaned and stood up straight. He winced and shook his head at Katsuki. “I’m fine, Kacc—Katsuki.” The quick shift of his name didn’t go unnoticed.

“I’m covering you,” Katsuki said sternly. “Don’t fucking argue with me.”

“Katsuki, *really*, I’ll be okay,” Izuku insisted. “You’re more useful on the full offense. You have weak points on defense.”

“*No*. You could get hurt.”

“Now it’s your turn to stop worrying,” Izuku cut him off. His eyes softened while he yanked down the rope and put it in his backpack. “I’ll be *fine*. *Really*.”

“I’m still fucking covering you,” Katsuki mumbled, narrowing his eyes.

Izuku sighed in resignation. He began to walk towards the back exit of the hotel property. Katsuki followed suit with his mind racing in several different directions.

How the hell could he be so stupid? He should’ve taken Izuku gently, or at least attempted to. Katsuki had never exactly been the softest in bed, he had always been naturally rougher. All his previous partners seemed to enjoy it—and he had defaulted to his usual choke and fuck state.

“You’re underestimating my endurance,” Izuku said casually as they walked towards the docks in downtown Nago. “I have a higher pain tolerance than you’re giving me credit for.”

“You make it sound like you get fucked before killing someone frequently.”

“I-I don’t,” Izuku stuttered.

“So, you’re just used to your ass being sore or some shit?” Katsuki mumbled, a little jealous of the other partners Izuku may have had before him.

They reached the boat docks and he walked slightly ahead. He caught sight of a small jet ski that was chained on the pier and decided that it would do. Whoever the owner was could miss their lavish ride for a little while.

“I, uh, actually never been sore like this before,” Izuku muttered after a pause.

Without thinking too much about it, Katsuki asked, “the others not get the job done well?”

“T-There have been no others. You were the first.”

Katsuki stopped in his tracks.

Izuku bumped into his back at the sudden halt. Katsuki whirled around, eyes stretched with disbelief. The mask Izuku had pulled over half his face didn’t hide the blush rising on his cheeks. Katsuki's face contorted with shock, and he quickly snapped his mask down.

“You were a fucking *virgin*?” Katsuki hissed through his gritted teeth. “Izuku—What the *fuck*?! Why didn’t you tell me that before?”

“I didn’t want you to overthink,” Izuku murmured. He shrugged and his eyes averted to the side.

“Taking your virginity is something *definitely* worth fucking overthinking.” Katsuki groaned. “Fuck. *Fuck*—Izuku, what the hell? Is that why you were so nervous?”

“Yes,” Izuku confirmed. “B-But I liked it! I really appreciated every second. I-It’s fine, Katsuki.”

“No, fuck that. It’s not fine,” Katsuki spat. “I choked you until you were basically purple in the face and—shit. I was so goddamn rough with you, and you’ve never been intimate like that—”

“—I *like* that you’re rough,” Izuku interrupted. His brows furrowed. “This is why I didn’t say anything. Plus, I was scared you’d back out because you wouldn’t want to have sex with a virgin. No offense but you don’t seem inclined to be someone’s first time.”

He wasn’t. He avoided virgins like they carried the plague—but for a good reason. He wasn’t delicate or gentle enough to give someone the gateway experience they deserved into sexual exploration.

“But there’s no use in talking about it,” Izuku said. “I don’t regret anything, and I hope you don’t either because I was a virgin.”

He started marching forward towards the end of the dock, but Katsuki quickly caught him by his arm and pulled him back.

“You still should have told me,” Katsuki whispered.

“So, what? You want a do over?” Izuku asked, entirely sarcastic.

Katsuki’s eyes burned holes into Izuku intensely.

He was stunted in the realization that he *did* want a goddamn do over. He wanted more than a fucking do over truthfully. He wanted more moments, he wanted to feel Izuku again and again. Help him explore his body and now that he knew he was Izuku’s *first* a large part of him didn’t want someone else to be his *last*.

“I—” Izuku swallowed and slowly pulled his face covering down. His eyes searched the ground, in his mind he was carefully choosing his next words. “I never felt like the moment was right before you. I wanted it to be special.”

Katsuki’s heart hammered at a tempo faster than he had ever experienced.

“And what made the moment right this time?” Katsuki asked.

Izuku smiled at him like he had asked a silly question.

“It was the right moment because it was you.”

Me? A warm sensation filled every fiber of Katsuki.

“W-We should—Um. We should get going,” Izuku muttered quickly. He dodged the way Katsuki was studying him and pulled his mask back up. “Let’s hurry over to headquarters before we let too much time get away from us.”

Izuku walked with a slight haste to the jet ski and Katsuki wordlessly followed.

Izuku began hot-wiring the jet ski expertly, purposefully not looking back at Katsuki.

As he did that, Katsuki studied Izuku.

He drank down the heaviness in the words and a small itch of possessiveness crept in. *It was the right moment because it was you.* The sentiment rattled, shook and imprinted on a very specific side of his mind. What Izuku had revealed was possibly the most special notion anyone had ever told him. It was as if he was given a gift that he normally assumed he’d break if he touched. But he *hadn’t*.

Izuku finished, paused and looked over his shoulder at Katsuki who hadn’t stopped his intense staring.

“Do you happen to know how to drive one of these?” Izuku asked. He was still blushing and not daring to meet Katsuki’s blazing gaze. “I realized that I don’t exactly know how to drive a jet ski.”

“I know how to,” Katsuki answered.

He stepped forward and mounted the water vehicle. He looked around at the black and silver gears and controls. It was vaguely familiar enough that he felt confident he wouldn’t crash and burn. Once upon a time, he had to learn how to operate one of these on the spot during an assignment. Katsuki revved the engine and speckles of water shot back on the wooden pier.

He nodded and then gestured for Izuku to get aboard. The other hitman climbed on, and snugly fit against his back. Katsuki tensed up a bit at the flush contact as Izuku leaned in and wrapped his arms securely around him.

“Make sure not to let go,” Katsuki instructed. Izuku squeezed him tightly and nodded.

Katsuki pressed the gas. As they blasted across the dark tinted body of water, Izuku gripped him hard. His head was tucked on his back and his hands held onto him with trust.

At that moment, Katsuki decided he liked the feeling of Izuku holding on to him.

☽ ☽ ☽

They arrived on Ie Island shortly after. The sunny paradise atmosphere of the island was drained away like someone had cut its jugular and let it bleed out. Lifeless and dull in a way to be unnamed. The leaning palm trees were ominous as they loomed over him and Izuku, as

though watching every step they took with unseen eyes. The stars were misaligned, and the moon was only a sliver of light in the sky, masked by dense gray clouds.

By the time they trekked up to the location of the headquarters, Katsuki could feel something was off in his bones. He didn't know exactly what—but he hoped he was wrong. Goosebumps ignited underneath his long sleeves, causing subtle, unsettling friction on his skin.

The forest of palm trees was nearly black. There was no visibility this late at night, and the moonlight was blocked from view in the canopy. The only thing Katsuki could see was Izuku's green eyes. They were sharper, deadlier than he had seen them before. There was an ice coldness that trickled out from the endless viridian the closer they came to the headquarters.

"Do you remember where the security room is inside?" Izuku whispered as they climbed.

"Yeah, I got it," Katsuki whispered back. "We'll go kill the lights once we get inside."

Izuku nodded in affirmation. They went up one last familiar hill and stopped on top.

The wind howled a loud warning as they peered down. The gray, concrete warehouse sat there, waiting for them. The white dove symbol appeared dark and as though it was painted in blood, chipped and worn down. The building had several lights on, some flickering and some dim.

As they surveyed the scene, Katsuki could see two figures that resembled Moore and Koizumi walking inside the front door with a third party. The unidentified man was slender, tall, and had black hair. He was dressed up in expensive, tacky clothing. A bright green tie. A dark green suit. He even had large emerald rings all along his hands and an emerald brooch pinned to his blazer. It was weird as hell and Katsuki could only conclude this man had a lot of money and was obsessed with the color green.

Accompanying them were the two faux bartenders from earlier in the week, looking over their shoulders for anything suspicious. But despite their watchful eyes, they missed the cloaked hitmen lurking from up above. The door clicked behind the party of trafficking men as they walked into the hidden headquarters.

Izuku and Katsuki quietly descended, careful of all the branches and twigs along the way.

They eventually found themselves up close and personal with the tattered concrete building. The texture of it was rough, and there were security guards making their rounds they carefully slipped by. They discreetly shuffled around to a side door when one guard veered to the other direction at the sound of something in the distance. The guard stayed gone for a moment, and that was enough time to sneak in.

Izuku plucked a neat, silver instrument from his harness. Katsuki had assumed it was a tiny knife, but when he took a closer gander it was a small lock picker.

Izuku kneeled down, carefully working his hands in sharp, twisting motions until the lock popped. Katsuki grabbed his gun and Izuku armed himself with the twin fang daggers.

They crept inside carefully with Katsuki leading first. He carefully peered around and was taken back by what he was seeing.

The inside of the warehouse was an entire contrast from its shabby outside. It was neatly put together, like they had entered some royal, grand hall. There was red carpet rolled out on the marble floors like delicate welcome matts to lead the way. The walls were painted a crisp charcoal shade of gray. There were even mahogany tables shelving fine, white porcelain vases and wax candles. Up and down the halls were planted mini trees every few spaces, giving the building a polished feel.

It was strange, how well put together this all was. It did nothing to help the growing goosebumps racing down Katsuki's spine. But what staggered him most were the walls.

The large halls were lined with luxe oil paintings much like Moore's private lounge. Only difference was that these portraits resembled Moore like shadow reflections. They were paintings of men and women with his facial features. Light brown hair. Light brown eyes. They were all in white suits, posing regally in plush, red chairs with their legs crossed. In every single painting the succession of people were all proudly wearing golden dove pins.

The cold, judgmental eyes of the paintings stared down at him as if they could see.

"Let's hurry and get the fuck out of here," Katsuki hissed lowly for Izuku to hear. "This place is giving me the damn creeps."

The other hitman glanced over his shoulder, clicking the side door shut carefully and re-locking it to cover their steps. Izuku stared up at the paintings, making eye contact with one before nodding in agreement.

The pair worked quickly, shuffling in and out of hallways, careful not to make any sound as they crouched low. Katsuki had memorized the layout of the building and their first stop was the security room. It was on the other side of the mysterious structure and required them to be extremely cautious. As they were crouching, ducking from pillar to pillar and corner to corner, a herd of footsteps came their way.

Both of them froze and they rapidly blended into the shadows. They pressed their backs against a wall out of sight as the group of men passed by.

"Do you have my companion ready today? Or do I still have to wait?" An unfamiliar voice asked. "I thought you said you would have him for me to inspect."

"Ah, we've had some trouble obtaining him," Moore's voice answered. The cheery, delightful tone was gone, replaced with a dangerous edge. "But not to worry, it was a minor snag with unpredicted weather. We'll make sure you'll be in possession of him soon."

"Thank you," the voice said. "When you said there was someone with green eyes, I couldn't help myself." There was a deep chuckle. "I love green. And you said he also has green hair?"

“Yes, beautiful green hair. He is stunning,” Moore tacked on. “Very sweet personality as well. He’ll make a good companion once you break him in.”

“Perfect. I always knew I could depend on a member of the Moore family to get me what I wanted. Your family has always done such good business in companion trade.”

Katsuki frowned deeply because he knew who they were referring to. The way they spoke so fucking *casual* about Izuku as if he was an item made a deep, disgusted flicker spark inside of his chest. His nostrils flared.

He looked to his side to stare into the very same green eyes they were currently discussing. There was a distant, pensive tint inside of them now. That usual sweetness drained as the voices faded away with the footsteps. The group of men walked up a large, spiral staircase as they continued to discuss their trades. When the footsteps and voices were no longer audible, Katsuki pointed down the next hall and signaled left for which direction to veer.

They moved quickly, dodging any one along the way. Men dressed in gray suits with loaded machine guns indifferently strolled up and down the grand hallways, talking about their days as though this was a regular night for them.

When they reached the security room, they crouched low before peering inside the open door. Inside were screens stacked on top of screens, showing all the different hallways. Tiny room numbers and locations were labeled at the bottom of each screen. Inside were two men, chatting and drinking coffee with their feet kicked up on the control panel. They were barely glancing at the screens, talking about something utterly useless.

“Look, I’m telling you BTS paved the way,” one of the men said. “It’s undeniable that they were one of the first pop groups from Korea to reach all the way across seas and break down the doors for others to follow suit.”

The other security guard scoffed. “You’re fucking joking. There are other groups besides BTS. You’re only saying that because you’re biased.”

“I’m not biased, I’m just not *blind*. Other groups, sure, are good but they don’t have Kim Namjoon.”

Katsuki made a move to get up and hurry and knock these idiots unconscious before his ears started bleeding. However, before he could, Izuku held up a hand for him to stop. Katsuki watched curiously as Izuku took out a small, slender contraption that mimicked a blow dart. He loaded up two darts that were labeled with the word ‘curare’.

Izuku carefully sank to the floor and aimed the small weapon. He sharply blew into it, tiny needles flying true to land in the necks of both men.

“Shit!” One of them yelled out and snapped a hand up at his throat. “What the fuck is this?!”

Panic swelled like storm clouds in their eyes as they pulled out the small needles. They hastily searched around, looking for where it came from. But they didn’t see either hitman outside the door, ducking out of sight. The security guards tried to reach for a red button to

call for help but quickly failed. Both men went slack and dropped to the ground with their eyes wide open.

Izuku and Katsuki stood up slowly and walked inside. Izuku quietly closed the door. Katsuki stared carefully as Izuku put the small blow dart back in his harness's pouch. He briefly wondered if Izuku always had that tranquilizer on him. How had he never seen it before?

He looked down at the men who were struggling, flailing on the ground like fish out of water.

One attempted to reach up for him, clearly a distressed cry for mercy. But fleetingly, their motions went slack. Heavy limbs slumped against the floor and the voluntary movement twitched out of their bodies gradually until there was none. Both men's expressions were wide with fear, shock and pure, palpable agony. The whites of their eyes slowly turned burning red from the lack of blinking. Tears gathered but never spilled on the edge of their eyes and there was a soft, strangled noise that sounded like a prayer.

"How long until the tranquilizer wears off?" Katsuki asked.

"It doesn't," Izuku said simply. He stepped over one of the men on the floor. He didn't bother glancing down at them. "It's a mixture of tranquilizer and a subtle, untraceable poison. Their hearts will stop soon."

Katsuki stepped over their bodies as well to get a better look at the area. Dirty cigarettes were in ash trays, and their guns were sitting next to black flasks that reeked of alcohol. Next to their guns was the red button the one man had attempted to reach for. It read 'Emergency only: Building Lock Down' in big, black lettering with an override key sitting next to it.

Katsuki then looked up at the bright screens. On the televisions they could see a mix of different things occurring in the large building.

But as he took in the various happenings, Katsuki felt sick.

On at least three small screens was the view of red decorated bedroom chambers. People were copulating inside of them, naked bodies tangled all around each other. Some in groups and some in pairs. Other screens held empty rooms, weaponry stashes, and others showed the inside of what looked like a dark, dreary gray room. At least ten different men and women sat inside, caged up inside of steel boxes behind bars.

There was no audio, but Katsuki could fill in the silence. People were weeping and screaming at the top of their lungs, voices hoarse no doubt. Some were knocked out, face down in their own vomit in their cages while others were curled up in a fetal position rocking back and forth.

Katsuki's stomach twisted in sickness and the burn of acid ate away at the back of his throat. He realized what that screen was. Then he realized what those red rooms were. Katsuki's skin crawled at the disheveled appearance of some of the people on screen, and he nearly hurled when he recognized a woman from the hotel. She was bleeding from a cut on her forehead with a ghostly look in her eye.

“Fucking bastards,” Katsuki spat distastefully. He gripped his gun harder, suddenly fueled with a lot fierier rage than before. He fucking hated humans like Moore and Koizumi.

Scum, Katsuki thought bitterly. *All of them.*

He snapped his eyes down at the men on the ground and was happy when he could see the life in their eyes was gone. Their gazes were unfocused now, and their mouths hang open with slight froth forming on their dry tongues.

Fucking good.

Katsuki curled his upper lip and rebalanced himself from the disturbing imagery. He turned to Izuku but was surprised to see the other hitman leaning over the control panel, still intensely locking eyes on the screen that held the captive group of people. Etched on his face was something Katsuki had never seen there. It was purely vicious, sharp, and deep with hate.

Izuku didn’t move as he stared at the static filled screen and the people crying out for help.

“Are you alright?” Katsuki asked after a while.

“They’re keeping people in cages,” Izuku hissed. The furrow in his brow deepened.

“I know,” Katsuki muttered. He scowled in distaste as he glanced back at the bodies on screen. “But they’re all going to burn in hell soon. Shouto and Inasa are going to come after and the bust I’m sure is going to set the people free.”

Katsuki looked down at Izuku’s hands. They were clutching the edge of the control panel with such intensity the leather of his gloves threatened to snap.

Katsuki wearily glanced at Izuku. “…Are you sure you’re alright?”

“Ye-Yeah, I’ll be fine,” Izuku whispered but his voice was slightly unsteady. He shook his head, snapping himself out of an unknown spell and peeled his hand away from the counter. “It looks like the business deal is taking place on the third floor in a room called 3A.”

Izuku pointed to one of the screens in the upper right corner. Sitting there was Moore, Koizumi, and whoever they were selling to. Their bodyguards stood behind them and it seemed like there was another stocky built man in there as well, standing behind the buyer. The audio was mute as the trio of men probably discussed Izuku. Papers were signed and laughs were exchanged as the men shook hands with pointy, greedy smiles.

Katsuki glanced towards the kidnapped people on screen then to Izuku.

“Let’s get started,” Katsuki said slowly as his hate spiked. He pressed the bright red ‘lock down’ button and pocketed the override key into his pants. “I’m ready to put a bullet in the roof of their mouths.”

The bright lights in the building killed and panic lights flooded all over. The red lights from up above tinted everything in deep shades of scarlet to match the emotions coursing through his veins.

☽ ☽ ☽

A dark, crimson rage pumped through Katsuki.

He could feel it crawl up his legs, wrap around his bones and make his body its home once more. He was familiar with this sensation as he and Izuku walked through the dark building like they were its owner. They listened to the guards scatter all around, yelling out commands. Everyone was panicking, saying they had to protect Koizumi and Peter from any possible intruders.

They gradually made their way up the stairs towards room 3A with movements that were more hostile but still reigned in. While there was a shift in Katsuki, there was also a shift in Izuku. Katsuki recognized something in the green painted hitman had switched seeing those people on screen. His movements were far less ‘going with the motions’ and now they were vicious with a deadly bite.

Every guard they encountered they dropped dead in one swift shot. Izuku used knives that were coated in poisons to take down anyone who came too close and Katsuki sniped dead anyone that was within his vision. By the time they cut their way up to 3A, clear intent to kill flashed in Izuku’s beautiful venom eyes.

With the two of them, they took down the guards outside the door with no issue.

But while watching Izuku squeeze the life out of a man in a lethal headlock with his legs, Katsuki comprehended he had never truly seen Izuku’s deadly side. The other man had been pulling his punches and techniques with him for eight years. Blood drained from the guard’s face as his skin ripened to blue then purple. His brown eyes rolled back like he was finally called by an Angel of Death to return to the ether.

When Izuku released the man, shuffling on the other side of the door was audible. Click clacking of expensive dress shoes against marble floors echoed and hush voices murmured. Then quickly, the sounds disappeared. Izuku stood upright in an alerted position and pressed his ear carefully against the wooden double doors.

Katsuki snapped both security guards’ necks to ensure no mistakes were left.

“Something is happening inside,” Izuku muttered carefully. He leaned in more with a concentrated expression. “It sounds like—”

But before Izuku could finish his sentence, the wooden double doors opened with great force.

The sudden shocking slam sent Izuku stumbling backwards. He quickly caught himself and Katsuki lifted his gun to immediately fire it. Standing there were the three bodyguards, faces twisted with scowls and murderous intentions. Their guns were pointed, and it only took a second for them to try to kill them.

Katsuki quickly dodged when a storm of bullets rained down and Izuku did the same. Izuku quickly disarmed one bodyguard, taking his gun and shooting him between the eyes. Katsuki

shot the hand of another, forcing the man to scream out and drop his weapon then landed a bullet in his temple. Katsuki sharply turned his gun on the third guard that Izuku had begun struggling with—but the two were too close. They were exchanging blows back and forth far too rapidly for Katsuki to take a clean shot.

The bodyguard had swiftly taken out a knife and attempted to slash for Izuku's throat but failed and cut his suit instead. Izuku hissed as he staggered backwards and looked down at his torn piece of clothing. It limped forward to reveal his clavicle area and tattoo.

Katsuki was about to jump in, but in the background, he could see Moore fleeing with his business partners. The three elder men were shooting at them as they attempted to get away at high speed.

"*Shit*," Katsuki cursed, and he ran inside the large room.

He dodged more whizzing bullets that came close to nicking his skin. Gracefully Katsuki changed out handguns to fire expert sharpshooting. Three of his bullets landed. One in the unnamed negotiator's skull and the other two lodged in Koizumi's shoulder and the back of his knee. Both men dropped to the ground as Moore looked down at them in terror.

There was a split second where Koizumi and Moore held eye contact. But it didn't last long. Moore fled down the stairs, leaving the bleeding man on the ground.

A flash of hurt trickled onto Koizumi's face right before a loud gunshot rang out.

Katsuki whipped his head to see Izuku holding the last bodyguard's gun to the man's chin. Blood painted the ceiling, walls, and across Izuku's face. Speckles of red decorated on the sliver of his skin that was showing, blending with the look of lethality burning in his eyes.

The man's eyes rolled back, and his body slumped to the ground.

Katsuki took off after Moore as Izuku rounded on Koizumi, who was attempting to crawl towards his gun. Izuku ran to him and quickly stepped on his hand. Koizumi hissed and tried to pull back, but Izuku dug his heel in and pinned him in place by holding the barrel of the gun to his head.

Katsuki's vision was straining in the dark, red lighting. All the hallways stretched long like an endless nightmare as he searched around for Moore. Along the way, he cleanly shot down several guards who were too slow for his reflexes.

He searched for a while. He checked every room, kicking down every door, not leaving a single one unturned.

Eventually he walked up to those chambers on the top floor and barged in on the sex parties happening. Several naked people scattered as Katsuki pointed his gun to them. He was about to land a bullet in all their skulls but halted when he caught sight of bruises and ankle bracelets on some of the people. Those people had the most fear in their eyes. It was spiraling with dread, brokenness and they nearly looked like they *wanted* to be shot.

There was only one person in this room who didn't have an ankle bracelet. It was a larger man, who appeared entirely healthy. He had gaudy, glittery rings on his fingers that shone in the dark, red lighting. Then, as Katsuki was surveying him, he noted the golden chain around his neck. It had a golden dove pendant.

Katsuki's rage intensified. It trickled up the back of his throat when he put together the pieces.

He pointed his gun at the piggish man with the rings. The bastard was trembling behind one of the frail men with an ankle bracelet, using him as a human shield. The captured man's bruised face silently begged Katsuki. That helpless, hollow look told Katsuki what to do. Without batting an eye, Katsuki expertly shot at the top of the gaudy man's skull, not hurting the whimpering man. The large body staggered back into the wall, painting the wall red. All the men and the women in the room stared up at Katsuki, like a blessing but still terribly afraid.

Katsuki put his finger over his masked lips in a 'shush' motion.

"You never saw me," he said very seriously. "There will be police here soon. When they arrive, you're going to tell them there was some type of deal gone wrong. Got it?"

They all frantically nodded.

Katsuki walked into the next two chambers and did the same thing as he searched for Moore.

His frustrations began to grow when he couldn't find the kingpin. He peeked behind every corner—he even checked that disgusting cellar holding the kidnapped people. That was worse than he thought when the putrid smell of vomit mixed with human waste slammed into his nose. Their screams and cries were a high-strung disturbing melody that would haunt Katsuki for years to come.

When he searched up and down the whole building, Katsuki headed back to the room with Izuku and Koizumi. The other hitman was carefully staring down Koizumi, who stared him down right back.

"You know," Koizumi said coyly. "I recognize you even with that mask, Hiroji. Green eyes are a rarity after all and that was your selling point to the buyer. But I suppose Hiroji is not your real name, is it?"

Izuku stayed unfazed and didn't take the bait. No use in talking to a dead man, Katsuki figured.

Koizumi then looked at Katsuki who walked up to them. He chuckled and shook his head. "And Taro. *Of course.* I knew there was something off about you two. But of course, Peter never fucking listens to me."

Katsuki ignored Koizumi's bitter ass rambling and turned to Izuku.

“I can’t find him,” Katsuki explained with an edge. “There must be a secret room in here somewhere. I checked everywhere.”

At that, Koizumi gave a tell: his face faltered for a millisecond too long and Izuku caught it.

“You’re right and he knows where,” Izuku said flatly. He dug his foot into Koizumi’s hand and looked him in the eye. “Well, I guess this is the part where you tell us where he went. I’m sure you know there’s a hard way to go about this and an easy way. It’s in everyone’s best interest if we can do it the easy way.”

“I’m not telling you two anything,” Koizumi said through his gritted teeth. He winced in pain as he tried to shift off his shoulder but failed. “Both of you can go to hell.”

“Alright, I guess this is going the hard way,” Izuku said tiredly.

He smiled from under his face covering, eyes unnervingly polite as he shifted his gun to grab one of the blue needles on his waist. It was the one Katsuki had remembered as filled with a muscle paralyzer. Izuku had casually explained it to him before they left. He detailed that half a dosage was enough to immobilize someone while a full dosage was enough to make someone’s heart stop beating and kill them.

Izuku uncapped it and poised himself to stick Koizumi in his neck, most likely for a half dose.

But in the next instant, Koizumi decided to fight back. He grunted loudly, pushing through his pain as he grabbed for Izuku and the needle. It caught both hitmen off guard, and by the time either one of them realized what was happening, Koizumi had pinned Izuku down on the ground, and snatched the syringe from his hand. He rammed the needle into Izuku’s neck and Izuku screamed loudly in pain.

Katsuki saw bloody red. “You son of a *bitch*—”

Before he knew it, Katsuki instantly bum rushed Koizumi. His fist balled up tight enough that his leather glove tore at the seams and he slammed with all his weight into Koizumi’s skull.

The sickening crack of bone could be heard against his brass knuckles. Koizumi’s nose broke, teeth chipped, and blood sprayed around. Katsuki hit the man hard enough to nearly break his neck as his head whipped around and his eyes rolled back. He slumped to the ground coldly.

Katsuki’s expression immediately shifted from livid to worried.

He frantically bent down to Izuku who was slowly pulling out the long needle from his neck. His eyes were screwed shut as he let out a small gasp. Katsuki hastily took the syringe and pocketed it and began inspecting the site of injury.

His heart was pounding furiously. He had never had this happen before—feeling his emotions flood with worry, fear, and fucking *terror*. Suddenly, this assignment didn’t matter too much

to him anymore. The room warped like he was viewing it through a fisheye lens as he stared around at all the dead, bloodied bodies.

He scrambled Izuku into his arms and hastily lifted him.

“Izuku, we need to get you out—”

“—I-I’ll be fine,” Izuku whispered painfully. He sucked in a small breath as he tried to lift his arm. It was sluggish, but still mobile. “It’ll pass in a few minutes. Put me back down.”

“A few *minutes*?” Katsuki hissed like Izuku had gone mad. “What the fuck do you mean? That was a full dose.”

“Mithridatism,” Izuku said with a smile. “I have immunity to most toxins. T-This dosage was a bit high, but I’ll rebound in a second.”

Katsuki was rendered speechless.

He *heard* of consuming poison in increments to become immune to it, but only people who had a fucking a death wish practiced that. It was taboo and immensely understudied. But clearly, reckless ass Izuku didn’t give a shit about all that. Gradually, Katsuki’s heart slowed down from the racing tempo it was in. He lowered Izuku back on the ground and just like Izuku said, the man recovered within the next five minutes.

Izuku shrugged it off like he had merely tripped over a rock and stubbed his toe. He sat forward and worked the crick out of his neck and stretched.

Katsuki stared at him in disbelief.

What the fuck?

If he was questioning if he was truly pining after Izuku before, he sure as hell was now. What a perfectly deranged little shit.

Izuku turned to him and gave his cheek a quick pat. His eyes turned up into happy crescent moons and Katsuki could see the outline of his smile behind his cloth.

“You’re very sweet for caring like that,” Izuku said gently. “But I told you no more worrying for you too.”

“Right,” Katsuki said. He nodded dumbly.

It terrified him how *quick* he had been to throw the whole assignment if it meant Izuku was about to possibly die. He stared his emotions directly in their face, and they murmured back at him: “You care about him more than you think you do.”

As Izuku stood up, Katsuki realized he was much deeper in his affections than he thought.

Fuck. What was he going to do about that after all this?

“Help me tie him up,” Izuku said. “He’s the only person that can tell us where Moore is hiding. Our best shot is interrogating him.”

Katsuki shook himself out of his thoughts and focused back on the assignment. What he was *supposed* to be doing. While they dragged Koizumi’s body, Katsuki stole tiny glances at Izuku and felt his heart hammer rapidly.

☽ ☽ ☽

When they finished tying Koizumi up, Katsuki took a look around the room.

This must be where they negotiate deals Katsuki thought to himself as he stared around the high ceiling.

It was similar to the dining hall at the hotel, in an eerie way. Only difference was the layout was darker with deep, maroon-colored walls and gold trimmings. Off to the side of the room was a flamboyant display of wealth. Trophies, autographs and even a baseball collection of cards, bats, and a collector’s edition of used gloves.

There was a crystal chandelier overhead that reflected the emergency red light in a hauntingly beautiful way. The scarlet light speckles mimicked blood drops in Katsuki’s mind as they blended with the actual blood that was all over the room. Katsuki squinted in the dark lighting, surprised to see on the top of the ceiling was a replica of the mural in the dining hall.

But this painting continued past the last panel back at the resort.

His morbid curiosity studied the last half of the panels. Izuku caught him staring and looked up with him. Up above they could see the continuation of the story.

Next to the panel with the angel holding their dead lover was the angel descending down below to hell. Angry flames in the shape of hands pulled at the angel’s wings as he walked on hot coals to the deepest, darkest parts of the underworld.

“Seems like the story did have a continuation,” Izuku said curiously. He tilted his head as he looked at the other panels. “What a weird thing to leave out. Maybe he did that to scare people? It looks like the angel goes to hell to retrieve his lover’s soul to rectify his betrayal.”

Katsuki looked at the last panel, and it was just that. The weeping angel was cradling the transparent soul of their dead lover and floating back to the surface. He looked at the strangely painted face of the crying angel, howling in pain. An ominous feeling like snakes slithering under his skin occurred, and Katsuki quickly felt creeped out.

“This place is the fucking worst,” Katsuki mumbled, disquieted.

He shook his head and walked over to where Koizumi was tied up. The man’s head was limp as his arms and legs were bound to the large, lavish wooden chair.

Katsuki slapped Koizumi awake with a vicious backhand. The man’s head snapped to the side and a loud groan spilled from his lips.

“Wake the hell up, you fucking disgusting pig.”

Koizumi bobbed his head and he hazily looked around, clearly disoriented. He tried to jolt forward but was held tightly in place by the brown ropes and duct tape that bound him to the chair. There was a subtle flicker of satisfaction that rang out in Katsuki’s core as Koizumi gazed up in fear.

Koizumi studied Izuku and Katsuki who were standing in front of him with their arms folded. Izuku was leaning against the table in the fancy room while Katsuki was looming over the chair.

“W-What—Where am I?” Koizumi’s groggy voice asked. He looked around frantically, darting from the doors to the walls. His desperation quickly turned to distaste when he caught sight of the three dead bodies on the floor, blood pooling around them. His eyes then snapped back up to Katsuki and he glared sharply. “Where’s Peter, you fucking *vermin*?”

“We were sort of hoping you’d tell us that,” Katsuki said casually. He reloaded his gun while looking down at Koizumi. “Seems like your lover exited somewhere—but the building is on lockdown so he couldn’t have gone far.”

Koizumi chuckled darkly. “You two imbeciles. He’s probably going to the control room to get the—”

“—Override key?” Katsuki interrupted. He held up the silver key by the loop on his finger and dangled it tauntingly. Koizumi’s face faltered and Katsuki cocked his head to the side. “We got that covered. No one is getting in or out of here without our goddamn permission.”

“Or over your dead bodies,” Koizumi snapped. “This building is full of armed guards.”

“Who are now dead,” Izuku rebutted tiredly. He looked at Koizumi with slight impatience as he glanced at the clock. “Your only chance of getting out of here alive is letting us know where he went. We can offer you a trade of sorts since he’s our mark and not you. We’ll let you go in exchange for him.”

Katsuki held back a smirk because Izuku was lying through his teeth.

“No.” Koizumi shook his head and frowned until the lines on his face pulled tightly. “I’m never going to let you two go and slaughter him.”

Izuku walked up to him, leg still slightly limp and crouched down to Koizumi’s eye level.

“You would die for him? After he left you here?” Izuku asked coldly. “Is that really someone you want to protect?”

“I love him. I would give my life for him.”

“And I’m sure he’s counting on you to do just that,” Izuku said with pity. “You’re disposable to him. He didn’t even look back when he fled.”

“You don’t know *anything*. He’s going to come back for me because he *loves* me.”

“Are you sure about that?”

There was no answer. Koizumi’s face twisted with sincere doubt.

Katsuki could tell Koizumi wasn’t sure if that was true. He had been abandoned by the man he loved, traded in for his own life while Moore would go home to his waiting wife and continue on like nothing happened if he made it out of here alive.

Gradually, Koizumi began chuckling and hung his head. His weathered body shook with his eerie laughter, slipping into a spiral of doubt. When he looked back up, his hateful dark eyes mimicked voids of endless loathing. They were saturated with turmoil and spite.

Then as Koizumi stared at Izuku, the slashed part of Izuku’s suit fell forward once more.

The flap of material limped down and revealed Izuku’s ‘217’ tattoo for Koizumi to see. Izuku hastily slapped the cut piece of material back over his skin, but it was too late.

“Wait—*that tattoo*,” Koizumi whispered, sounding astonished. His eyes inched wider and wider by the second and Izuku looked like he committed a grave mistake. “I *recognize* that type of tattoo. You’re from the Viper Academy. Aren’t you?”

Katsuki frowned in confusion as Koizumi started laughing more. The laughter became dripped in sarcastic, cruel undertones that made icicles form along Katsuki’s spine. Koizumi’s dark eyes dug into Izuku like he found an old wound that he was ready to rip open for pure enjoyment.

“Oh. You poor, pitiful creature,” Koizumi continued with an unhinged smile. “This makes an unbelievable amount of sense now. Let me guess, One is upset with Peter for cutting our deal with him and telling him to go to hell? Did One put a kill order on Peter because they have to find the next round of kids themselves?”

Izuku didn’t say a word.

Katsuki grew disquieted at the implication.

Find kids?

Katsuki’s brain paused as he pieced it together. He sharply cut his gaze to Izuku, and the other hitman’s collective demeanor slipped slightly. Izuku’s nostrils flared, he cocked his gun and pointed it directly at Koizumi’s face.

“Tell us where Moore went,” Izuku hissed dangerously. “*Now*. I won’t ask again.”

“What number are you? I didn’t get a good look,” Koizumi said lazily. He seemed not to care that he was staring down the barrel of a loaded gun. “200s I think I saw? Was it above 250 or below?”

“His number...?” Katsuki whispered carefully.

217.

Katsuki's stomach turned.

"I said tell us where Moore is," Izuku demanded more forcefully. He pressed the end of the gun between Koizumi's eyes. "Quit trying to talk around this."

"Ah, right. 217. You're *below* 250," Koizumi continued. He smiled with all his bloodied teeth, mocking Izuku. "That means you were one of Peter's first deals when his father handed him the torch of the White Dove business, say…about twenty-three years ago? Did I get that correct? You look about the right age."

Izuku's hand shook, and his face twisted with sheer anger. "*Shut up*—"

"—No. Let him speak," Katsuki said suddenly.

A piece of Katsuki was twisting and his eyes were wide at what was being said. Katsuki grabbed the end of Izuku's gun and peeled it away from Koizumi's face. Izuku nervously swallowed. Through their connection at the weapon, Katsuki could feel small shakes and tremors.

"When you say deals, you mean *kidnapped*," Katsuki corrected, sickened.

He thought about the people in the cages with sunken eyes, screaming out for loved ones.

"No. I actually mean *sold*," Koizumi spat out unkindly.

Katsuki's grip on Izuku's gun grew tighter as Koizumi continued.

"If that's his number, then his mother sold him to Peter when he was under the age of five because she couldn't handle taking care of a child, needed money, and wanted a discreet way to continue on with her life. At the time, we were helping parents who had some unfortunate life circumstances start over by getting rid of children they couldn't or simply didn't want to take care of. Not all took the offer to give us their kids. But some did—seems like *his mother* did. Which means he's the 217th child to be sold to the Viper Academy."

Katsuki whirled his head to Izuku who's eyes were wide and glossy.

Tears were threatening to spill any second as his shaking grew worse. Quickly, Izuku snapped out of it. He violently snatched his gun out of Katsuki's hold and took a large step backwards, unable to meet Katsuki's eye. He snapped his mask off his face like it was suffocating him.

"I've heard so much about you band of fucking homicidal brats," Koizumi teased with amusement. "Which one are you? Are you a regular for hire or part of the Viper Seven? Perhaps the viridian viper? The horned viper? Or the double headed viper?"

Katsuki took one look at Izuku and knew which one he was.

"There's so many more of you, but those are the ones I hear graduated top of their class," Koizumi continued. "I always wanted to see how Peter's first shipment grew up. You all were so tiny when I picked you up that day."

Katsuki's chest wretched painfully as the truth slammed into his body: Izuku was trafficked.

The horrific, petrified expression on Katsuki's face must've been potent because Koizumi began to laugh again. This time the chuckle was crazed and the trafficker's whole body shook with twisted delight. Both Izuku and Katsuki stood still, too stunned to speak. Koizumi hummed happily, soaking up the disturbed expression on Katsuki's face.

Katsuki studied Izuku's shoulders. Waves of uncontrollable tremors raked up and down Izuku's body.

"What? Is this news to you?" Koizumi taunted Katsuki. Wide, mortified scarlet eyes tore away from Izuku to the man in the chair. The twisted man was smiling past the blood trickling from his nose. "You must not be from the Viper Academy then, you're far too stunned. But I'm curious, you two are killing partners and you didn't know he was groomed for this?"

The words stung like a swarm of wasps digging into his heart.

Katsuki had to take a step back when a familiar, depraved feeling clawed at his sternum. It rumbled and pushed against his chest, beckoning to break free from the imprisonment of his self-control.

In rapid succession, every memory of Izuku flashed before Katsuki's eyes.

He saw young Izuku, smiling and laughing with him all the time with purple bruises. He saw the busted lips and the way his face would sink whenever the clock would hit 22:22. It all rushed past him at lightning speed without the delicate romanticization. Now he could clearly see the dark pieces stick out like jagged edges, and they cut him deep. He saw Izuku's soft smile in Vienna and how sad he looked after killing Rin Hiryu. Then finally, he saw all the moments they had shared in Okinawa and the intimate night they had in the pale moonlight.

His world tipped on its head.

Katsuki walked over to Izuku and carefully placed his hands on his trembling shoulders. Automatically, Izuku flinched. Out of fear or shock Katsuki wasn't sure and that only fed the clawing that was growing harsher inside his chest.

"Izuku. You're shaking," Katsuki whispered.

Katsuki turned Izuku around, forcing them to meet eyes. Shame was painted all over Izuku's face. The tears that had been holding on for dear life in his eyes earlier had spilled down his freckled cheeks. He stared around the room, clearly caught off guard.

"S-Sorry. I—" Izuku started. He stopped and his face twisted in hurt. He hung his head away from Katsuki. "G-Give me a minute to re-balance and I'll be fine."

"Is what he said true?" Katsuki asked slowly. His grip on Izuku's shoulders tightened when Izuku didn't answer. "Tell me it's not fucking true," he desperately whispered through his gritted teeth and his nostrils flared. "You chose this life…*right*? You weren't forced into it?"

Izuku tried to pull away, but Katsuki dug his fingers into Izuku and forced their eyes to meet. "*Izuku*. Answer me."

"I—I didn't want you to know." Izuku's voice shattered.

Katsuki's heart broke in half and out crawled a monstrous entity.

He could feel it rumbling and clawing deep in his core. The urge was so potent and poured out over him as he thought about Moore and Koizumi. He wanted them to bleed. He wanted them to fucking *suffer* for what they had done. Scarlet eyes darkened into swirling pools of blood and a vicious snarl pulled on Katsuki's lips.

"...Go sit down until you stop shaking," Katsuki instructed calmly.

Izuku made a confused face but did as he was told. He sat down slowly into the plush cushion of the chair while looking at Katsuki slightly baffled. He wiped his tears.

Blazing scarlet eyes cut sharply towards Koizumi.

Katsuki's shoulders squared out, his scowl deepened and the depraved being inside of him began smiling with all its sharp teeth. With meticulous consideration, Katsuki weighed his gun in his hand and decided it wouldn't do. He put it back in his holster.

He walked slowly, keeping his eyes trained on Koizumi in the quiet room. When he stopped, he was standing in front of the wall full of baseball merchandise. He surveyed the precious collection of signed baseball bats that were hanging up under spotlights.

Katsuki reached for the heavy metal one.

He weighed it in his hands. Heavy. Dense. Exactly what he wanted. His cold eyes read the black signature on it that spelled out 'To Koizumi, thanks for coming out to the game!' in neat handwriting.

"I see you're a person who likes baseball," Katsuki said casually. He stepped back and gave the bat a test swing with perfect form and full strength. It cut through the air sharply. "Y'know, I'm a big fan myself. I have a couple of bats at home too. One is called Ground Zero, and the other one is called DynaMight."

He swung the heavy item over his shoulder and sneered in Koizumi's direction. He walked back over to stand in front of him, other hand clenched in a tight fist.

Izuku stared, confused but intrigued.

"You two really are insane," Koizumi said tiredly. "Why are you talking about baseball—"

"Just sharing some *facts* since you seem to like to." Katsuki squatted down low and tightened his grip on the baseball handle. "But I'll get to the point. I'm a hitman, and you're keeping my mark from me. I hope you don't think you can wait this out and believe this will be over if you get free somehow." Katsuki lowered his voice to a menacing tone. "I specialize in tracking and torture. It's a selling point of my portfolio that I *never* leave a loose end."

Koizumi scoffed. “Are you gloating about being a *murderer*—”

“—Only as much as you’re gloating about being a *human trafficker*,” Katsuki spat back. He stood up and lowered the bat off his shoulder. “But I’m warning you what will fucking happen if you don’t cough up where Moore is right now.”

“I’m not telling *trash* like you anything.”

“You need to be mindful of how you fucking speak to me,” Katsuki warned darkly. He held up the end of the bat and tilted Koizumi’s chin to look at him. Crazed scarlet eyes gazed down into the man’s soiled soul. “I’m a fucking sadist at the end of the day. I’ve worked in this field for nearly ten years. It’s hard not to enjoy it a tiny bit—especially when it’s *scum* like you. Hell, I’m so cruel I’m sure you might’ve heard of me.”

“No.” Koizumi leered. “I don’t think I have heard of an *arrogant*, blond hitman.”

Katsuki cocked his head. “The Scarlet Eyed Killer.”

Then like a switch, recognition sparked along Koizumi’s face. His age lines tightened when his eyes grew wide and there was a flood of disbelief then finally the horror set in. Katsuki smirked maliciously and pushed the bat further into the pale neck, but only enough to cause some discomfort. He enjoyed the way the blood from Koizumi’s mouth trickled down his pale, trembling neck.

“Ah. There it is—the *fear*,” Katsuki mocked.

He applied more pressure until Koizumi choked.

“So, you *have* heard of me. I’m sure you know then, I’m the person gangsters request by name when they need someone handled and *want* them to fucking *feel* the agony in every single bone. I don’t do the job without pain unless *instructed*.” Katsuki leaned down and smirked menacingly an inch away from Koizumi’s face. “And guess what? I wasn’t fucking instructed to for this assignment.”

In a swift movement, Katsuki leaned up and reeled back.

He gripped the handle of the bat with both hands and swung full force with all his rage into Koizumi’s knee cap. An ear shattering scream was punched out of Koizumi as his bones broke under the sheer strength. Koizumi began struggling and screaming desperately. In the process, he tipped the chair over on its side, and Koizumi tried to crawl on his side out of his restraints.

Katsuki unkindly kicked the man on his back with all his leg strength. He felt his foot punch deep in Koizumi’s stomach to the point the man gagged like he was going to vomit. The chair turned from the force, putting Koizumi on his back again, groaning in pain.

Katsuki snarled and pressed his foot on Koizumi’s bobbing neck. He applied all of his weight until the man went deliciously purple in the face and his eyes bulged wide much to Katsuki’s

satisfaction. He dug his heel in further, resisting the urge to stomp Koizumi's pearly white teeth in when he realized he still needed him to talk.

He stepped in on the pale throat like a footrest as he landed another devastating blow to Koizumi's other knee cap. All his disgust, rage, and blood lust fueled his swing as he dug his heel into Koizumi's throat until the man started violently coughing.

"Next is your goddamn rib cage," Katsuki growled. "Be wise with your next words when you open that filthy mouth of yours."

He lifted his foot off Koizumi's neck and the man began sobbing instantly.

Tears streamed down his face as his mind, no doubt, was blank with thought numbing pain. Katsuki counted to ten for a possible answer for Moore's whereabouts, tapping the bat against the floor next to Koizumi's head with each number. But nothing came as Koizumi gasped for air. Katsuki shook his head and took his stance again. He landed another hard blow, this time directly to Koizumi's heaving chest.

The sound of ribs breaking mixed with another scream. The noises bounced off all the dense walls in the room as Koizumi coughed up blood in spurts. The dark liquid trickled down the sides of his lips. Katsuki 'tch'd, disgusted as Koizumi gagged to breathe.

"If you don't tell us where he went in the next minute, I'm going to smash your skull in," Katsuki warned serenely. "And trust me, I'll have fucking *fun* doing it."

Katsuki dragged the bat up to Koizumi's chin and rested it there for a thoughtful moment. Koizumi looked at the door, as if waiting for Moore to come back and save him. But no one arrived. The ticking clock inched tick by tick as all three of them waded in time.

Katsuki saw despair enrapture Koizumi's face right before he reeled back again and swung.

"—W-Wait!" Koizumi hoarsely yelled right before the bat nearly collided with his jaw.

Both Izuku and Katsuki froze.

"I-I know where he went. I-I can tell you—" Koizumi began coughing violently.

The battered man choked up more blood, gargling the dark liquid as he attempted to talk. He sobbed and a tear raced down. Koizumi screwed his eyes shut as he struggled to breathe and mumble. His words were so minced that neither one of them could understand what he was attempting to say.

Katsuki decided to have a lick of mercy. He bent down and lifted the chair back upright to prevent the man from drowning in his own blood. Koizumi spat out large gushes of crimson liquid onto his own lap as he violently shook. He heaved through his broken chest as he stared at the floor. Katsuki pondered what was hurting more, his broken body or his broken heart?

"If I tell you where he is, will you let me go?" Koizumi asked, riddled with despair. "I'll say I never saw you."

“Of course,” Katsuki lied, humoring him. “Now, where is he?”

“There’s a secret safe room in the basement of this building off the charts, in case something like this was to happen,” Koizumi confessed. “It’s in the closet labeled ‘SR’. You’ll open it and it appears like a normal custodian closet. But if you pull back this piece of wood on the side, there’s a hidden door. He’s possibly waiting there for more of his men to come. You can only get in and out with a key he and I have. I-It’s in my pocket.”

Katsuki reached forward and dug in Koizumi’s blood-soaked pocket. Just like he said, there was a small golden key.

“Now.” Koizumi coughed and spat out blood onto the ground. “Can I go? I’ve been humiliated enough.”

Katsuki pocketed the key and circled to stand behind Koizumi. He put down the bat and unsheathed his blade. It shone in the dim, red lighting of the room. In the reflection he saw his bloodthirsty eyes staring back at him. They were furious, angry and called to him to make sure he made it *hurt*.

Katsuki finally lifted his head and locked eyes with Izuku.

Izuku was sitting there, astonished. He even seemed possibly impressed—taken back in a good way. A piece of Katsuki was afraid Izuku had seen his cruelty and would think of him differently, but after what was revealed—this kill was different. Violent vermilion eyes met vindictive viridian. Understanding was exchanged and Izuku looked at him with a subtle, thankful expression.

Katsuki placed a hand on Koizumi’s shoulder to steady him as he pressed the blade at his throat.

“The murder or the suicide?” Katsuki asked Izuku.

A litany of confused sounds erupted from Koizumi. He wheezed out his last words that were bargains for his life. Money. Women. Men. All the shiny things in the world that glittered gold, but Katsuki was only interested in seeing him bleed red. The voracious side of Katsuki ate up every sob and cry. It fed into his satisfaction that this scum was begging for his life at his hands. Katsuki gripped Koizumi’s hair and yanked on it to keep him still as he held the blade into his bobbing throat.

Izuku’s face flashed with some level of pity. But that notion was swept away the longer he looked at Koizumi begging for his life.

“The suicide,” Izuku whispered. “Let him have his tragic ending for his tragic love.”

Katsuki smirked and Koizumi screamed more.

“I think that’s a perfect ending for his story, darling.”

Katsuki slit Koizumi’s throat while holding eye contact with Izuku.

☽ ☽ ☽

The secret room was exactly where Koizumi said it was. When they pulled open the door, there they found Peter Moore, cowering in the corner of the dark room.

"*Koizumi*? Is that you?" Moore's shaky voice asked. "I-I called for backup, they should be here any moment now. Sorry I left you! I had to get to a place to call to make sure people came."

Katsuki flicked on the lights. Horror painted Moore's face at the sight of the blood splattered hitmen standing calmly at the doorway. Katsuki rested the bloodied bat on his shoulder and Izuku calmly cleaned his dagger.

"Sorry," Katsuki said cruelly with his blood stained smirk. "We're not your lover, but we have come to collect your heart."

Izuku lifted his dagger and expertly slung it in Moore's chest. The king pin's eyes went wide as he looked down at the sharp metal lodged in his heart like he was a piece of cheap wood. The wound bled red all over Moore's white suit, soaking through. The liquid crawled into the fabric, covering the golden dove pin with a deep red. He started convulsing as blood spurted up from his lips.

Moore's last words were a mixture of calling out to his wife and Koizumi that he loved them.

☽ ☽ ☽

It took them longer than Katsuki thought to stage the scene and properly cover their tracks. A sprinkle of sunrise crept through the windows as they worked. They wiped the security cameras of evidence and strategically placed bodies to look like a fierce coup. An even number of men on both sides, violently killed in a shootout. In the process, they found a blade that matched the structure of Izuku's to put in Koizumi's cold hands.

In the end, they placed Moore and Koizumi side by side, Romeo and Juliet style to sell the scene. The stage was set to look like Koizumi had stabbed Moore in the heart then slit his own throat directly after in a brutal, final scene of their love affair.

As they did this, Katsuki was elated.

It warmed his heart to know these criminals were gone, wiped clean from fate's slate. However, he couldn't shake how disturbed he was by what Koizumi revealed. No amount of blood lust could make that go away, and the more they moved away from the assignment—that fact weighed down heavier. Izuku was a victim of trafficking and he had been sold into a bloodied life against his will.

Izuku was quiet and refused to meet his eye.

He nearly seemed ashamed and there were tears clinging to the edge of his eyes as they cleaned any stray blood splats off the walls. When they changed into their hiking attire and exited the scene, the mood shifted drastically.

The sun was peeking up from over the horizon now, spilling hues of burnt orange and golden yellow across their skins. They trekked deep into the woods on the other side of Ie Island, far away from headquarters and near the more deserted regions. Izuku was walking ahead of him clumsily, pushing away branches and leaves from his face. Every motion he did held frustration, anger, and there were tiny sobs leaking out from his mouth.

It was painful, listening to that.

Katsuki's whole chest felt like a bomb had exploded inside of it, and all the wreckage contained within him was unsalvageable.

"Why didn't you tell me?" Katsuki didn't recognize his own voice. It was broken, hurt. "Izuku, why didn't you fucking *tell me*? I feel like a goddamn idiot. All this *time*."

He could see young Izuku smiling and how the freckled man acted like an innocent child at the tiny things like baking. Relaxing. Dancing on the boat. Making fucking smores. Enjoying reading his romance novels—saying how he thought a life like that would be nice. All the memories twisted painfully, and tears pushed at the back of Katsuki's eyes at the thought that Izuku would have to go *back*.

"You weren't supposed to know," Izuku whispered through his gritted teeth. "*No one* is supposed to know that."

"But why not tell *me*?" Katsuki shot back. He tried to rush forward and stop Izuku who simply yanked himself out of his grasp. "Izuku, don't fucking do *that*!" He snapped.

He grabbed Izuku more forcefully this time and spun him around. He made them stand still in the middle of the dim forest with the sounds of the birds chirping beautifully for the wrong moment. Katsuki's tears started pouring when Izuku finally met his gaze. Izuku was shattered. His face was full of steady streaming tears, rims puffy as his body began to shake.

"Wh-Why couldn't you tell *me*?" Katsuki asked. His grip on Izuku tightened. "You were fucking trafficked—And, this whole fucking *time* we talked about doing this job for survival but you didn't have a fucking *choice*."

"I *do* do this job to survive," Izuku said woefully. He whipped out of Katsuki's hold and glared defensively. "What do you think would happen to me if I *refused*? I'll end up how Hiryu did in Vienna—hunted down by everyone I grew up with because that academy forces people to not have a lick of *empathy*. None of us have a real choice. But the only choice I do have is to make sure I *live*."

Izuku's tears finally broke through like a dam.

He cried heavily and his face twisted full of sorrow. This was the first that Katsuki ever saw Izuku weep like this.

"But I didn't want you to *know*." Izuku's voice was scratchy and hoarse. "I-I didn't want you to think I was fucked up and taint your memories like you had said that day. I didn't want you to think the boy who saved your life was just some psychopath in training. You saw how you

reacted when I called you Kacchan the first time by *mistake*. Why would I willingly tell you I was raised to kill?"

Katsuki winced and his heart shattered further.

Izuku cried softly and pressed his hands into his eyes. "I wanted you to think I was normal like you—pretend I was the regular person I'm not. Is that so bad?"

"I'm not normal, Izuku," Katsuki whispered. He stepped forward. "I shouldn't have said that to you. I lashed out and I don't think that of you at all. I'm the furthest fucking thing from normal but I—I don't know what to think about the fact you were *sold* into this. I *chose* this life. That's far more fucked up than someone who didn't get a say in it. I woke up one day willing to kill. You never did."

"That's not true." Izuku shook his head and stepped back. "In my type of program, you're trained to kill. You get bloodlust instilled *very* young," Izuku said seriously. "I woke up one day willing to kill just as much as you were—but the difference is I didn't have regular feelings like you. You did it out of desperation with your back against the wall. I did it because it was a Thursday afternoon."

"But that's not fucking fair to you. You should get a *choice*."

"Life isn't *fair*!" Izuku nearly yelled. "It never has been because not everything is about *free will*, Katsuki! It doesn't *matter* if I was trafficked or not—I am still a *killer*. All my life I have only pretended to be a normal person, mimicking what I see in those *books* and *movies*. I have no clue how to be in love or be kind. I pretend like I am because when I read, I-I think it might be nice. B-But I don't even know if I'm *capable* of it outside of pretending. So, it doesn't *matter* if I was trafficked, if police showed up at my door they're not going to let me go because of some sob story. They would think I'm better off dead because it's too late for me."

Katsuki's eyes softened as he stared at Izuku's tear stained face.

"You're more than capable of being kind, Izuku. I'm living proof of that."

Those were the words that broke a fragile part of Izuku.

"I know." Izuku chuckled sadly and clutched above his heart. "A-And that's what's confusing. When I'm with you, I've never felt like I was pretending. In Tokyo, I cared for you so much I knew it was real. B-But, I lost it after you left. Then when we met in Vienna, even though I didn't know it was you—I felt a flicker for a while. I pitied you, and I hadn't pitied anyone for a long time until Vienna. A-And now, h-here in Okinawa, I feel like I actually lo—"

Izuku's words halted. His eyes grew sadder.

A gust of wind blew.

"…Why am I telling you this?" Izuku whispered distantly. "We're never going to see each other again." His smile twisted into the saddest thing Katsuki had ever seen. "You're going to go live the normal life you deserve in the countryside and I'm going to go back to my family in Tokyo. I-It doesn't matter how I feel."

Katsuki reached out, trying to stop Izuku when he took off deeper into the forest again. He was tipping, clearly drowning in his dark ocean of thoughts.

"Izuku, wait—*shit*," Katsuki cursed when he nearly tripped over a root. He looked up to see Izuku disappearing quickly away from him. "Izuku! *Wait*!"

"—No. I'm d-done." Izuku shook his head and walked further. "This is done. I-I can't keep looking at you. It's starting to feel like I'm torturing myself with something I'll never really *have*. W-We should part ways early, I promise I'll send you what you need for the divorce, but I c-can't do th-this. You weren't supposed to *know*—"

Katsuki rushed forward, pulled by the part of his heart that didn't want to be separated from Izuku. He grabbed onto the weeping man, who was suffering from his own overwhelming panic.

Izuku struggled against him, and once again it all felt familiar. Familiar like the last eight years of assignments. Familiar like the rose garden. Familiar like they always were a push and pull of desperate forces compelled towards each other. But in this instance, it was unfamiliar in the sense that for the first time, Katsuki knew he could never let go again.

They stepped in tandem in the tussle, and part of the ground cracked under their weight.

It happened quicker than either of them could think.

Izuku gasped when the ground underneath his feet gave out. He slipped backwards uncontrollably, and Katsuki yelled in sync with him as he went toppling forward, breaking through the surface.

Katsuki knew this feeling.

He had felt it in his dreams, and it was just as terrifying to feel it in reality. They were free falling in darkness and it was utterly suffocating. His vision was useless and all around him echoed the sounds of breaking branches and leaves. Izuku clung to him, petrified. When they slammed into the bottom, the sound of several bones snapping breached Katsuki's ears.

Izuku screamed at an ear shattering octave.

Katsuki's whole world was disoriented in a dizzy spin. His vision was dark. His body hurt and there were little chokes and cries coming from underneath him. The desperate sounds forced him to register that he had landed directly on top of Izuku, who broke his fall. But in the process—he broke Izuku. Katsuki scrambled off, mortified when Izuku bawled in pure pain.

Dirt, twigs, and leaves fell all around them like confetti. Katsuki hastily looked around.

They were in a pit. A fucking *hole* in the middle of the forest.

Izuku was struggling to sit up as he attempted to roll on his side. Nausea rocked through Katsuki when he caught sight of Izuku's ankle, it was twisted in a sickly direction it shouldn't have been. Izuku looked down at it, and another agonizing sob escaped him.

"*Katsuki*." Izuku curled into the dirt. "M-My leg—"

"Don't move," Katsuki said hastily.

He sat up on his hunches frantically looking around the pit's dirt floor. He saw several branches and decided they would do. Ignoring his own pain, Katsuki took off his backpack and picked up one branch. He snapped it in two on his knee. He tried his best to work quickly, Izuku's whimpering was getting progressively worse. Katsuki worried what other parts of his body were possibly broken from the drastic fall.

Katsuki took his shirt off and ripped it in two. He shoved one half of the cloth in Izuku's mouth and began to properly position himself.

"This is going to hurt," Katsuki warned. "On three, okay?"

Izuku nodded and screwed his eyes shut.

Without bothering counting to three, Katsuki immediately shifted Izuku's ankle in proper positioning. Izuku screamed into the cloth and the feeling of several broken bones rolled under Katsuki's fingers. He winced. It was *much* fucking worse than a simple twisted ankle, bones were probably cracked, shattered and disordered. Izuku needed extreme medical attention.

Katsuki tried to ignore how it hurt him to hear Izuku's muffled cries as he made a makeshift splint for Izuku's ankle. He wrapped his piece of torn shirt around Izuku's throbbing ankle and the two branches. He tied it tightly enough and it broke his heart to see Izuku's wrecked face. The other man's fingers were digging into the dirt, and he looked as though he was stuck in multiple types of agony.

Katsuki finished and gave Izuku the painkillers in his backpack. He positioned himself against the dirt wall of the pit and pulled Izuku between his legs. Whimpers, hisses, and whines fell from Izuku's lips as he was hoisted up to rest against Katsuki's chest. Strong arms wrapped around Izuku's torso to keep him upright as his head tilted back on his shoulder.

When Izuku seemed steady enough, Katsuki finally tore his attention away from him. He stared up, fucking *baffled*.

They were extremely far down, so far below the surface that the opening above looked like a measly little circle. The sun was seated fully in the sky now, shining down on them tauntingly. There was no possible way to climb out and the trap had been covered up so well, it had to be dug on purpose.

This was most likely laid out by goddamn Moore in his human trafficking schemes. Katsuki hadn't realized how far they had gone into the forest on the island, but apparently it was far out enough Moore and his associates felt comfortable to lay traps to kidnap people.

"I forgot for a second this place could have been rigged like Yanbaru," Izuku said, tiredly. "I should have been more careful."

"Even in death that bastard is a pain in the ass." Katsuki scowled. He picked several twigs and leaves out of Izuku's messy curls. He tried his best to rub the dirt off of the freckled face. "We should call someone to come. It won't mess up our alibi."

They did just that—but when they tried their cell phones there was no signal.

Of course, Katsuki thought sourly. *The fucking booby trap would fall right out of cell-phone bounds.*

"I guess we're stuck here until someone shows up," Katsuki said wearily. "How's your leg?"

"It hurts so much," Izuku said, voice riddled with pain. "I don't think I've ever broken my ankle like this."

"I think it's shattered in a couple of places," Katsuki said while examining it. "You're not going to be able to walk on it for at least a couple of months."

Izuku made a disgruntled sound like that was *very* bad news. Katsuki could feel him stiffen and it hurt his goddamn chest to think about what was causing Izuku fear. He held him tighter for more than one reason.

They didn't speak for a long stretch.

Time passed by enough to make Katsuki feel the bitterness of his regrets. This put all his interactions with Izuku in a new, horrifying light. Broken bones. Busted lips. The abandonment. The failed plan to run away. That last bit was the worst. It made his guilt multiply to the point he swore he would be crushed under its weight.

"I should've come back," Katsuki's voice broke in two as Izuku held on to him. His eyes shed tears he could no longer hold back. He needed a way to rectify this, but he just didn't know *how*. "I wish I fucking came back for you."

Izuku didn't say anything, he was too focused on his breathing. Blistering pain was budding all over his body.

"Do you have to go back?" Katsuki asked, his face twisted with desperation.

There was a plea of '*don't go'* hanging in the air.

"I do." Izuku shook his head, exhausted. "Someone will notice if I'm missing quickly. There's not really another alternative, and it's alright. I've accepted this, Katsuki. Anything you think of in the next ten minutes, I have already thought of in the last twenty-five years of my life. It's all the same path in the end."

It wasn't right.

It wasn't fucking *right*.

Katsuki clenched his teeth to prevent from cursing and throwing a fit.

It was sickening to think that Izuku was surrounded all his life by blood, not by choice. Izuku took care of him as a kid, hell, even now, Izuku still somehow worried over him while they were at each other's throats. Izuku always did little things to prove he was inherently *kind*. But knowing Izuku was raised to have that kindness plucked from him like some rotten tooth was upsetting.

Katsuki didn't know what to do. But he knew he couldn't accept it.

"Was your surname ever Mamushi?" Katsuki questioned, horribly piecing it all together.

"Legally, that is my surname. Originally, it wasn't," Izuku answered tiredly. His eyes were closed, and his face was twisted in pain. "I found out my…my real surname was Midoriya. But Midoriya Izuku drowned in the Shinano river when he was two according to the records."

There was a small pause.

"I—I don't know why I'm telling you this," Izuku whispered. "I'm not supposed to be. If my handler found out I was acting like this I would be killed."

"Why killed?"

Katsuki swallowed and held Izuku tighter.

This was getting worse and worse as Izuku talked.

"Because I'm defective," Izuku said quietly. "My program is efficient for weeding out weak emotions that could cause problems later down the line. We are not supposed to feel like this, having a panic attack. Or worse—caring about someone who isn't one of our own."

Katsuki wondered how the latter was worse than the former. But he held his tongue as Izuku continued to spiral.

"We've been conditioned to be desensitized and detached from the outside world. Brutally. Over and over to the point I'm sure most of my brothers and sisters only find joy in bringing pain to other people. If it somehow got out that I have been showing emotions for someone outside my circles, especially since I was a *kid*—"

Izuku's face doubled in pain. He shifted in Katsuki's arms and shook his head.

Upon hearing those words, Katsuki considered Izuku's kindness. Specifically, he thought about the little things. How Izuku helped him with the romance issue. How Izuku woke him up from a nightmare on the first night. How Izuku gave him his pineapple on his drink when

he saw that Katsuki enjoyed the fruit. His eyes softened as he reflected on his, because Izuku wasn't the picture he was painting.

"I've tried to get out before when I was younger," Izuku admitted. "Don't think I haven't. When I realized what was going on, I did try. But i-it's complicated now. I don't know anything else, and I can't leave my family behind. This is just my fate."

Fate.

Katsuki's heart hummed low. "Do you even want to do this job?"

"There's—There's not much else for me to do," Izuku said reluctantly. "Think about Hiryu. He got out and he could only find work at another place still killing. Why would I leave now? I know it's hard to understand, but the people I grew up with are my family, and I'm comfortable with them now. It's complicated but we do all care for each other in a twisted way and I-I'm not *miserable*. We have good moments together, and I'm taken care of really well by my big brother despite everything."

Big brother.

Katsuki had to resist scowling.

Now he could deduce Izuku's 'big brother' was another trafficking victim he was close with. Like Izuku said, it was twisted—but it was his life.

"How did that type of program go under the noses of the police in Tokyo?" Katsuki asked as he held Izuku closer. "Some law enforcement had to know. Fucking *someone* had to realize what they were doing to *kids*."

"The city of Tokyo is aware." Izuku laughed brittlely. "Specifically, the governor of Tokyo. My class was his special investment so he could have personal trained assassins. He's not in direct contact anymore since he's chosen who he wants. He bought them a long time ago off the Academy, but he still keeps a close eye on the operations."

It all clicked together when he thought about the information in his red folder.

Government officials—the fucking *governor*. That was *his* company's client.

He cursed loudly and threw his head back against the dirt wall behind him. He screwed his eyes closed when it all made so much fucking sense. The shady government officials put a hit on Moore because of a poor deal. Izuku's handler put a hit on Moore because of the same reason—they were hired to kill him on the two separate sides of the same coin.

Izuku whimpered in pain again when he shifted.

Katsuki hesitantly lifted a hand to stroke Izuku's hair. He did this over and over to calm Izuku, but to also ease himself. Eventually, Izuku fell asleep from the painkillers and exhaustion.

In contrast, Katsuki was staring blankly at the other side of the pit, struggling to absorb the information.

His heart was hammering painfully fast.

☽ ☽ ☽

Eventually, the police raid occurred. It was perfectly timed really.

After the Special Assault Team infiltrated the warehouse, they found a bloodied scene that puzzled them. After closer investigation, and interrogating the victims inside, it was chalked up to a trafficking deal gone wrong. A sudden coup to take the White Dove business in a fit of passion and jealousy by Minoru Koizumi.

Katsuki stayed awake while they were stuck in the pit together. He placed a hand over Izuku's rapidly beating heart. The smaller man was in and out of sleep, struggling not to further irritate his injuries. The distinct sirens of the Special Assault Team inched closer and Katsuki immediately began screaming from help at the top of his lungs, playing the role of the distraught husband.

But it wasn't much of a facade anymore, was it? As he screamed for help, he was slammed with the fact that this emotion was very real. He was desperately worried over Izuku for more reasons than his broken ankle, and the man was his husband legally.

Footsteps and the sounds of dogs rushing towards them was the biggest relief to Katsuki. A flashlight shone down on them, and he squinted. Izuku roused awake, covering his eyes and looking up to their saviors.

"*Bakugous*?" Shouto yelled down, clearly horrified. "Hang tight! We're going to get you out of there!"

He rushed off before either him or Izuku could answer.

More people came, and they were retrieved from the pit easily. Izuku's whole body was taut with pain and Katsuki didn't doubt that he had whiplash himself. His neck was horribly stiff as they finally made it above the surface again. The morning air was sweet and refreshing in comparison to the damp, suffocating feeling of the pit.

The first people he saw were Shouto and Inasa. They were calm, collected and surgically professional in their tones now. There were no pink and purple vacation shirts or flip flops. Instead, all the resort gear was replaced with navy-blue detective's uniforms and shining badges hanging around their necks.

"Follow me," Shouto said, sounding panicked. He looked wearily at Izuku's damaged body and winced at the swollenness of his ankle. "There's emergency medical attention at the bottom of the mountain, let's get you there quick."

Katsuki carefully hoisted Izuku in his arms, and Izuku wrapped his arms around his neck and leaned into him. There was a great sadness in his motion as he stayed quiet, soaking up their

last moments together.

Shouto gestured for him to follow him out of the density of the forest. As they walked, Shouto awkwardly smiled at them both.

“Weird way to tell you guys, but I’ve actually been undercover,” Shouto confessed and Katsuki had to act surprised. “I was here to investigate an underground trafficking scheme called the White Dove. It’s run by a very shady family, and they’ve been slipping authority grasp for a long time. We had finally narrowed in on them this week after getting inside intel.”

“Wow, that’s awful,” Katsuki said in a fake tone. “Did you catch the guys?”

“Well, they seemed to have been killed,” Shouto said seriously. “Ironically, a lovers’ quarrel it seems like. That is what the witnesses who were rescued are saying.”

Katsuki nodded, relieved that their presence was undetected. He knew it would be. If he was anything, it was thorough, but it was reassuring to hear the confirmation.

As Katsuki looked around, he could see so many different departments of crime scene investigation patrolling all over. Police dogs were sniffing up and down the forest as chaos ensued. More booby-traps were uncovered, and secret passageways that tied back to the warehouse were revealed. Some other people were even rescued from ditches. A crying woman and man had blankets tossed over their shoulders as they held their arms closely on themselves.

As they walked down the hiking trail, the sun trickled in more and more.

“Are you two alright?” Shouto asked.

“We’re okay as we can be,” Katsuki answered. “We went for a morning hike since it’s our last day before we checked out. Next thing I know, we were falling into a fucking ditch.”

“I’m so sorry that happened,” Shouto said. “I know, uh, how much you two like your forest activities. This was not a good way to end your vacation together. Definitely a little traumatizing.”

If only Shouto knew how right he was.

Shouto looked at Izuku’s dirt covered, tear-stained face. Izuku was utterly out of it, eyes distant and unfocused. He was trying to cope with his physical and mental pain that was coursing through him. Katsuki could feel his dirt covered finger pads digging into his neck. To him, it felt like Izuku was trying to communicate that he didn’t want to be separated either without voicing it. And it tugged hard on his heart.

They reached the bottom of the mountain and there was a swarm of people buzzing like a hive.

Paramedics, police and health care workers were working overtime shouting codes that he didn’t understand. All of the people who were trapped in the warehouse were free now,

sobbing and having their wounds tended. Their hair was dirty, caked with dry blood and their eyes were nearly swollen shut from crying so much. Some victims had raw fingertips, likely from clawing at the cages or their skin. Others were eerily silent as their ankle bracelets were cut off of them to reveal vile lesions from the rust.

As they passed, two of the people in ankle bracelets squinted at Katsuki in vague familiarity. They focused on his eyes and there was a silent 'thank you' that was translated. However, Katsuki couldn't meet their gaze. His emotions were too out of whack that he had to close his eyes when they walked past them.

He gripped the smaller body in his arm close to his chest as Shouto led them to an unoccupied paramedic's station.

"Okay, you can get medical attention here," Shouto said. "Don't talk to anyone you see; we're investigating the crime scene."

Katsuki nodded like he didn't know what was happening. "Of course."

Izuku stayed quiet, not even acknowledging Shouto's presence. The detective noticed the distant, depressive expression and wearily looked between them.

"Is he okay?" Shouto whispered.

"He's just—" Katsuki stopped. He didn't quite know what to describe what had occurred. "He's just in pain."

"I'm fine," Izuku finally spoke up. He snapped out of his daze, and turned to Shouto with a plastic, apologetic smile. "Sorry for being so quiet, my ankle is throbbing and it's hard to focus."

"No need to apologize for being hurt," Shouto said with a kind smile.

The paramedic came up to them, gesturing with his hand to others in the background. They pointed to Izuku's ankle, and a white stretcher was brought. Katsuki felt his heart begin to pound and anxiety flushed through his veins.

The stretcher was laid out perfectly for Izuku, and Katsuki realized that when he put Izuku down—that would be it. Izuku would go back to Tokyo, they would get that divorce, and everything would continue on. Just like the way he wanted it to a week ago. However, his head was pounding in violent rejection of that as he stared around at all the victims. He kept seeing young Izuku and the number 22:22 flash on a little yellow watch in all too clear memories.

"Um, Taro?" Shouto asked.

He turned his head back to see Izuku, Shouto, and the two paramedics all staring at him like he had been asked a question. He hadn't heard it and he could barely hear anything now. The quick, pounding sound of his heart flooded his ears as he let the new facts about Izuku sink in.

“You have to put me down on the stretcher now,” Izuku said quietly, as if understanding. His hand gently caressed Katsuki’s shoulder as he looked up at him. “You have to let me go.”

Katsuki had a visceral reaction.

“No.”

Everyone stared at him, baffled.

Had he said that? Of course he fucking did. His lips moved before he could make the decision. He clutched Izuku tighter and realized fuck *that*. Fuck *this*. He looked around at everyone who was staring at him like he had said something puzzling.

“No?” One paramedic said. Her face deeply frowned and looked between the two men. “Sir, he needs medical attention right now—”

“—I mean, *fuck*, just hold on a damn minute,” Katsuki hissed. “I need to speak to my husband privately.”

He turned on his heel before any questions could be asked. Izuku was whipping his head between Katsuki and the medical tent, disgruntled. Katsuki walked far out of ear shot of Shouto and everyone else around them. They were now on the edge of the chaos, still trapped in the crime scene tape. Katsuki stopped and then looked down at the baffled, fuming man in his arms.

“*Katsuki*?” Izuku hissed in a low whisper. “What are you doing? I’m in *pain*—”

“—Come back with me,” Katsuki said quickly before he could change his mind.

Shock, surprise, then finally sadness set in Izuku’s face. He averted his gaze.

“I-I can’t do that.”

“Do you really think you can fucking work on assignments with as many broken bones you have right now?” Katsuki retorted. He was being pushy, holding onto Izuku uncomfortably tight like he might fade away. “What are you going to do about this, *hah*? Is your handler going to make you work through a broken ankle or some shit?”

“I *do* have sick leave believe it or not,” Izuku said with an edge. “I’m not treated like a slave. Injuries are frowned upon, but as long as I can prove I’m incapacitated, I’m allowed to have time to recover. I will just rest up before I get my next tasks.”

“Do you live alone?”

“Kind of, but what does that have to do with anything?”

“Is anyone going to help you while you recover?”

“Ye—” Izuku started and stopped. A look of realization hit him, there was a trickle of fear before he curled into himself slightly. “I-I’ll be fine. It’s not the first time I’ve broken a

bone."

"I can help," Katsuki pressed and Izuku assessed him wearily. "Only until your ankle heals. I'm sure you'll fuck it up worse if you have to do shit by yourself because you're clumsy like that. I can take out the trash, clean, and all that junk." Izuku tried to object but Katsuki spoke over him. "You *need* someone there to help you. You're going to be on crutches, or in a wheelchair. You can't just go fucking live alone for four months."

Katsuki wet his dry lips and held Izuku closer. "*Please*."

He never begged.

Fixing his damn mouth to beg was foreign to him since he only ever made others plead for their lives. But he fucking had to try. He couldn't fucking let Izuku go back—not right now. He wanted more time—no. He *needed* more time. Maybe this was indulgent in the worst damn way, but after all of this, he couldn't let Izuku go.

He just couldn't do it.

Katsuki could see Izuku teeter on a decision. He decided to push the balancing scales by laying himself entirely vulnerable. His eyes softened in a way only Izuku could provoke.

"Let me return the favor and take care of you until your ankle is better," Katsuki whispered. "Then we can go our separate ways. I promise."

Those little words seemed to do the trick. Izuku's eyes went from weary, to wearily hopeful. There was a sparkle of longing as Izuku glanced around like he couldn't believe what he was about to say.

"I-It would be risky for me to disappear that long," Izuku muttered. "Especially with someone. Th-They can't know about us. I could get in a lot of trouble for inappropriate copulation." His brows deeply furrowed, skeptical. But Katsuki could work with skepticism.

"How risky would it be?" Katsuki asked.

"If they see me being friendly with someone I risk termination."

"I promise where we're going would be isolated. You will be safe, no one will recognize you. It'll just be me, you, and this plot of land with a garden and shit. It's private."

"It's still pretty risky," Izuku said. He considered a thought and tilted his head. "B-But—I do have a favor I could call in, I suppose. One of my brothers owes me from a long time ago when I covered for him going out of range. He could cover for me going out of range this time."

"Do it," Katsuki said.

Their eyes met and Katsuki could feel the bad decisions against his skin. He thought about what Izuku said about getting in trouble for inappropriate copulation. Ironically, that mirrored

what Aizawa would say if he could see the scene in front of him now. Yeah. This was a big risk for both of them if he was being honest with himself.

“Okay,” Izuku said. He nodded his head, unsure but gradually smiled. “I’ll come back with you.”

Both men’s hearts hammered at the highest tempo possible.

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki never in a million years would have guessed life would take him down this path. If someone had prophesied this scenario to him a mere eight days ago, he probably would’ve shot them in the mouth for just suggesting such a damn thing.

But here he was, walking with the very same green menace he said he would kill on sight down the streets of Tokyo. Holding his bag on top of it. They trotted down the crowded sidewalks with Izuku hopping on crutches, his ankle was casted up along with one of his wrists that the medic diagnosed as fractured.

The crowded streets of Tokyo were exactly how he recalled them. Bright, bustling, and overwhelming. The Megatron screen shined down neon colors on them in the night scene as roaring engines from cars whizzed by. There were too many bodies pressed together and no one paid them any mind. They blended in with the lively sea of people who were going about their days in the late summer heat.

As they neared where Izuku lived, the other hitman stopped short. Izuku cautiously turned to him, green eyes full of warning.

“Put on your face mask and baseball cap,” Izuku said sternly. “You said you worked for gangsters sometimes, right? You don’t want anyone seeing your face here.”

Katsuki frowned but did like he was told. He put on his black mask and baseball cap. Izuku reached up with his good hand and snapped the rim low, shielding his eyes in the shadow.

Then Izuku led him to possibly the sketchiest part of Tokyo.

It was like entering the Bermuda triangle, a place of myth that didn’t exist in the real world. He had always heard stories of this area: *Hadesu*.

It was a street nickname, given by the people who had lived to witness it. But no one entered and exited here the same, or so he was told.

It was larger than he thought, like an underground city veiled away from the public eye. There were people in the street playing dice, gambling, and the sweet scent of market food wafted in the air to mix with nicotine. Loud music blasted from several windows like they were in the middle of a dark club as the streets became narrower and narrower. Bright neon signs flashed with promises of pleasure and wealth.

As they walked down the dense, sketchy street, several gruff people eyed Izuku with familiarity and scrutinized Katsuki. One man with a missing eye and the meanest frown he

had ever seen smiled sweetly at Izuku, who waved back. Then that one-eyed gaze sized Katsuki up, assessing if he was going to be a future problem. It felt like a million glares were digging into his skin as they walked down the cracked sidewalk.

We sure as hell aren't in Paradise anymore, Katsuki privately thought as he watched a gangster gleaming in gold walk out of some underground shop.

This was a place Aizawa and several of his colleagues had always warned him about. This is where murders and gangsters roamed free, staking their claim. It was made possible by the fact it was invisibly run by the underground Yakuza, drug lords, and gangsters who operated with politicians. None of the organized crime leaders disrupted the flow of the city, keeping all the atrocities they committed well hidden in the dark. And in return they were given this large section of the metropolis.

The pair of hitmen cut down one particular street that had several people dressed in fine diamonds and gold crawling up and down it. Their eyes were shielded by dark shades and on their hands were brass knuckles with fresh blood on it.

"Here we are," Izuku said suddenly.

They stopped in front of a high skyscraper made of reflective one-sided glass. Katsuki recognized it instantly. It was the *exact* building Moore and the governor stood in front of in that picture, shaking hands and cutting a red ribbon. The bastard had hung it up so proudly in his lounge like it was a lifetime achievement.

The building itself looked like an expensive apartment complex. The glass was one-sided, showing no hint of whatever was on the inside. The back of it branched out what looked like smaller buildings, and it formed the shape of a V with how long it reached. On the silver sliding doors in the front was the sigil that was stamped on Izuku's red folder: two snakes intertwining on a V.

The Viper Academy.

Izuku turned to him with a kind smile and then glanced around.

"You can't come in," Izuku said apologetically. "Go sit around the way out of sight. There's a small coffee shop, no one will bother you if you don't look at them the wrong way so keep your head down. Don't speak to anyone either. I mean *anyone*. There's a lot of, uh, odd operations around here and I wouldn't want you to accidentally be on someone's radar. I'm going to go pack my things for the next few months and ring in that favor."

"Sure thing," Katsuki said.

He reluctantly let Izuku take his suitcase. The smaller man struggled to maneuver his body with the large bag and his crutch. But Izuku managed. Katsuki sadly watched as Izuku limped into the shiny building, and the automatic sliding doors swallowed him whole.

Katsuki did as he was told and found that coffee shop.

It appeared like a normal cafe. Cute, aesthetic and had a good decent menu accompanied with outside seating. He ordered a medium coffee, black like his favorite color and sat down at one of the tables outside on the street. As he waited, he watched and observed the people passing by. Everyone here *had* to be involved in shady shit, Katsuki deduced.

It was a marvel that Izuku somehow still held on to his kindness if *this* is where he grew up since he was a child.

While sipping on his coffee, Katsuki sent Aizawa an update of the assignment from his laptop. He gave his standardized report of the assignment without the large, glaring detail about Izuku. He also left out the fact he was now a married man—which he would have to confront sooner or later.

He explained he had a sudden emergency to take care of at his property in Hokkaidō, which was *partially* true. Katsuki typed about how he would have to check in for retirement later. Aizawa would probably groan at that, but Katsuki wanted to get Izuku settled into his estate first before he came back down here. Plus, he wasn't too keen on Aizawa possibly *seeing* Izuku.

The kill order might not have had a folder, but his boss did not give those types of orders out lightly.

When Aizawa said kill, Aizawa meant butcher.

Right as Katsuki pressed send on his report, the loud sound of vicious dogs barking rippled into the air.

Everyone in the vicinity stiffened and jerked their heads at the sound. Some people even quickly walked in doors and others turned around from where they came. Katsuki frowned at those reactions. The fact there was fear on some of the most frightening looking peoples' faces here made him uneasy.

He inconspicuously turned his head toward the sound of the growling. Then from around the corner appeared a tall figure that oozed power in its most raw form.

His eyes were a deep red, cold like blood that had been left to cake on the ground. His hair was a unique white, tinged blue and cut sharply at shoulder length. The thick hair was pulled back into a half bun, half down to reveal his dangerously high cheekbones on his face.

Pierced eyebrows. Pierced ears. Pierced bottom lip with silver snake bites. Accompanying all of that was an endless sea of horned vipers were inked on his neck, arm and hands. The man flexed his large hands and the ripples of his skin made the river of inked snakes covering his hands and arms dance. Across his battered knuckles were the words "VIPER" and "SNAKE" in big, bold lettering.

The man's skin was so pale his veins were visible, branching all over like blue serpents underneath his skin. But what was most unsettling were the strange cracks in his face, like he had shattered and got glued back together.

Yet, despite this broken attribute, he seemed anything but.

There was something about his face that was handsome but worn. He was regal in the same manner that cracked oil paintings of forgotten emperors were. He was dressed in all black expensive clothing, silver chains that rattled, and a long black trench coat that nearly swept the dirty ground.

He leashed along three black Doberman hounds by metal chains in both of his entirely tattooed hands. On his fingers were obsidian colored snake tattoos that wrapped around each digit like rope. On his neck was similar ink work. Endless horned vipers that crawled up his pale body with their fangs bared, mimicking a necklace. His whole throat was covered in them, wrapping around his veiny skin.

People parted for him like they were in the Red Sea and he was their shadow Moses.

He walked by coolly with his head in the air like he was royalty. Eyes lifeless like a corpse and uncaring about the people around him. But it seemed like everyone else knew who he was because no one dared to breathe.

Then some drunken man stumbled out in the street and bumped right into him.

Everyone froze.

The sculpted pale face barely showed a drop of emotion. His upper lip curled, cracks moving with his porcelain skin. He lifted a snake covered hand, dropped the leash on one of his dogs, and gave a simple two-toned whistle.

Katsuki flinched and looked away from the scene when the dog attacked. Bloodied screams erupted and deep growling echoed into the night. Everyone in the vicinity turned away from the gruesome view without a word. Katsuki didn't have to watch to know the dog viciously tore through the man's flesh, the metallic smell of blood was evident. He could have sworn he even heard a bone snap in two.

Any other day Katsuki would've jumped in and stopped this. Clearly this was an *extremely* unbalanced punishment for fucking bumping into someone.

But he kept quiet when he glanced towards the shining building Izuku was inside of. He had his priorities, and this man wasn't worth the risk of fucking up and not getting Izuku to the countryside with him.

Then the mysterious pale man spoke in a daunting, raspy voice.

"That's enough, Atropos. Kneel."

The dog instantly obeyed, and all the disturbing ripping sounds ceased.

Katsuki dared to drag his eyes back to the scene.

The nameless white-haired man bent down and used a black hand cloth to clean the spots of blood off his shoes. He nonchalantly flicked the dirtied rag over the man's open wound like

he was a trash can. It unnerved Katsuki how he didn't bother glancing down at the man he had mutilated as he grabbed his dog's leash again. Katsuki watched, unsettled, as the man lifted his black dress shoes and stepped over the pool of blood.

The drunk, mutilated man was pleading for help. But no one bothered to aid him, and Katsuki could tell that was out of fear. Whatever power this man held, it was petrifying enough to act like daggers and pin everyone in place where they stood. All eyes watched the helpless man lay on the street and bleed out—but no one dared make a move or lift their head.

When the mysterious pale man passed Katsuki by, time slowed.

That glacial gaze turned on him. A surge of lethality stabbed into Katsuki like a million needles sinking into his throat. There was something so utterly empty about this man's eyes Katsuki had never seen. Endless red voids were bottomless with absolutely *nothing*. The cold gaze bored into him carefully, but not long enough to truly assess him.

Katsuki somehow felt degraded simply by making eye contact.

The dangerous eyes peeled away from Katsuki like he was dirt under the man's shoe not worthy of his presence. The white-haired man passed Katsuki by without stopping his stride and turned the corner. In his wake he left a cacophony of murmurs, whispers and people checking to make sure he was truly gone.

An unwanted shiver latched onto Katsuki's skin. He concluded whoever that was, truly was really bad fucking news.

After about an hour, the bleeding man finally got someone's attention. He was dragged away to get medical help and shortly after Izuku came to the coffee shop, completely unaware of what had happened. His freckled face held a cheerful smile as he tugged along a large suitcase packed to the brim.

When he approached, Izuku glanced down at the blood-soaked concrete but didn't bat an eye. Like it was a daily occurrence. There was a twitch of embarrassment on his face as he turned back to Katsuki. He quickly buried it, not wanting to dwell on asking what happened.

"No one bothered you, did they?" Izuku asked carefully.

Katsuki stood up, eager to get the hell out of this place and finally somewhere to relax.

"Nope. I minded my business like a pro," he said. "Let's go though. I bought some last-minute train tickets, so we need to hurry to the station."

Katsuki took Izuku's suitcase for him and the two of them headed out, leaving behind the dark segment of the city. As they were walking, Izuku's mood was elevated. Green eyes were shining wide, but also making sure to look over his shoulder—as if being careful not to run into someone. When they finally exited Hadeus, Izuku looked up at him with his darling doll face.

"So, where are we going exactly?"

Katsuki exhaled and thought about a place he hadn’t stepped foot in for years.

“My mother’s home.”

Chapter End Notes

Let me know what you think below! Questions, comments, screams, theories are all welcome! 💜 I hope you enjoyed this chapter. It is pretty much the full shift of the story into the next arcs. I'm really excited for it!

Comment from Beta Luna: I'm so happy Moore is dead. I feel like that one tiktok audio. I can't wait to go to his funeral, knowing we could have changed that outcome.

Thanks so much for reading!

Chapter 11: Interlude II

Chapter Summary

Katsuki finds out what the monster inside of him is.

Chapter Notes

Hello everyone! Welcome back to this lovely ride.

First up, please if you haven't seen the art done for ch. 6 of this story please go do so!! I absolutely loved it and added it to the end of chapter. It's so beautiful. Also special thank you as well to the artists who have drawn art from the story ;-; words can't describe how happy you all make me and how much I have stared at your art.

Thank you so much! Alright. Lets get into!

Warnings: Usual content warnings of dark themes, murder, and Katsuki being a pure menace.

See the end of the chapter for more notes



By Clanniegy

Chapter 11 — Interlude II

.

.

.

When Katsuki was thirteen, he tried not to blame his mom.

Really, he tried his best.

He tried his best when he got on that train and left the nook. Inquisitive eyes from other civilians were crawling up and down him, staring at his tear-stained face and he clutched the tiny white note in his hands. He read that line over and over again: I love you, Kacchan. Please come back. He wished he could hear those words in reality and not read them on this dusty, forgotten piece of paper.

He tried not to blame her as he thought about the boy with green eyes he would never see again.

It wasn't her fault. Right? It wasn't.

His mom needed him, and he needed to help her. He repeated this to himself until he believed it and the simmering flame of resentment under his skin subsided.

He tried not to blame her when the food ran thin in the house and so did he. He held his emotions back from peaking dangerously. All he wanted to do was break something. Destroy the most fragile thing he could find simply because he *could*. It was one of the few things he did have control over: breaking things. Kicking things. Slamming the ceramic mugs against the floor. When the stinging in his eyes became too great from looking in the mirror, Katsuki broke it too.

He tried not to blame her when he could see her leave with strange men, reeking of whiskey. Her face would be pretty and flush. Her smile would be beaming. He told himself she *deserved* to be fucking happy for once—even if that meant he felt like he was drowning.

He tried not to blame her when his shoes started to become tattered. The holes at the bottom of his soles were evident and other places of the rubber were so thin he could feel every rock and uneven surface. He had memorized the pattern of the cracked sidewalk as he walked home by himself every day.

He tried not to blame her when he found her crying over how hard her job was. He wanted to tell to suck it up and get the fuck over it. But he knew he shouldn't. He had no clue what it was like to walk in her shoes, and he did not press it. She reassured him the bills were being paid, and that's all he could really ask for. Even if there wasn't much food—he couldn't blame her for doing her best.

But it was getting hard.

Specifically, he found it hard not to blame her on one particular day.

Katsuki had taken up doing his dumb classmates' assignments for them in exchange for money. It wasn't a lot, but it was enough to make sure he had some substance in his stomach from day to day. It helped rid himself of the lightheaded feeling he was continually plagued with.

When he announced he was doing assignment for money, most of everyone who he knew to be mediocre came to flocking to him. They had never spoken to him before. Nearly a couple days ago, he was sure he heard one girl mention he stunk. But Katsuki didn't mind or care—he needed all the money he could get. So, he did them all, sometimes even at the expense of his own schoolwork if it meant there would be food in his belly.

But on this one day, he found himself tracking down some goddamn extra who decided not to pay him what they agreed upon.

The boy had run his mouth all over school. He boasted as he spread it around that he wasn't going to pay Katsuki because he didn't believe in paying '*trash*'. He even said that Katsuki was a lost cause that would die in the gutter where he bellowed with the rest of the city rats.

By the time Katsuki caught wind of the bullshit that was said, he was already planning the other boy's funeral.

The moment classes let out, the dumb fucker really thought he could outrun Katsuki. But the joke was on him—Katsuki always tracked down *anyone* who he needed to make pay. Katsuki had cornered the shaking boy several blocks from the school. The smaller boy was trembling, back peddling fast. But Katsuki didn't give a single rat's ass. He forcefully dragged the crying boy in an alleyway, and kicked him in the skull hard enough to make his dead ancestors feel it.

It felt good. *Cathartic*.

That simmering feeling in his veins erupted in that moment. He could hear that voice tell him to break the boy. Beat him until he was covered in red and never would fucking speak again. Upon analyzing these thoughts, Katsuki didn't realize how angry he had been. He got a grasp however when the full force of his swinging foot connected with solid bone.

The sickening crack was as satisfying as the broken mugs in the house.

A sharp yell violently echoed into the air as the boy's lip was split wide open, signaling he was in deep pain. This was a sign for him to stop. The boy had learned his lesson, but Katsuki wanted was to do it again and again and again—and *again*. When Katsuki felt that scorching anger boil sharply, he balled up his fist.

However, before he could give a full punch, the other boy screamed for him to stop and threw the money at his feet. Katsuki immediately halted and looked at the loose money on the grey pavement.

“Please! Don’t hurt me anymore! I’m sorry,” the pitiful boy sobbed. “I’m sorry. I’m so *sorry*.”

Katsuki’s face twisted in distaste.

But he struggled to understand the low, blue like emotion settled into him when he lowered his fist.

He felt disappointed—but he wasn’t quite sure *why*.

The silence swelled between them as Katsuki wrestled with the tugging emotions inside of him. One half told him to take the money and walk away. Spit on him maybe for good measure. However, there was another part of him that whispered to him to swing his fist. It spoke and said, who the fuck cared that this asshole gave him the money? Give him that black eye he *deserved*.

But Katsuki stayed still, shocked at the cruel nature that was itching in the back of his head.

He looked between his balled-up fist and the dirty money on the ground.

Then the loud sound of footsteps approaching snapped him out of it. He quickly picked up the yen that was ungracefully tossed at his feet, ignoring the droplets of dark red blood on the tips of his tattered shoes.

Katsuki counted the money patiently.

It was way more than they agreed upon. The poor dumbass probably just handed over whatever was in his pocket. Katsuki turned his sharp glare on the bleeding boy on the ground, grabbed him by the hem of his shirt and leered down into his face.

“You call me fuckin’ trash ever again and I’ll beat you so badly you’ll never walk after I’m finished,” Katsuki hissed menacingly. “Don’t ever ask me to write you goddamn paper for you either. Have fun fucking failing.”

Katsuki turned on his heels to walk away in the dark. He pocketed the money, went to the grocery store and bought enough food for the next two days for him and his mom.

On his walk home, Katsuki hated how this was familiar. This was beginning to feel like routine, Katsuki learned after a couple months of telling himself he needed to step up and be better for his mom.

She smiled every time he brought home some level of food, and it pleased a very specific side of him. Eventually she started leaning on him to bring in dinner after school. She questioned where he was suddenly getting the money, and he was honest with her. She gave him a sad look, and he could tell she wanted to say more but didn’t. Instead, she patted him on the head and called him a smart brat.

As he made his way home with two full bags of food, Katsuki observed all the kids his age. He tried to push back the envy he held for them. But it was difficult.

He strolled into the sterile, nearly barren apartment and it was quiet.

There was barely a sound echoing inside, and it made Katsuki frown the second he walked through the doors. Usually there would be the upbeat tune of whatever game show on the TV playing, or the sound of his mother's laughter on the phone with whatever man was up next.

But there was none. The darkness was suffocating the apartment like a thick blanket.

Katsuki put down all his bags carefully and flicked on the light switch.

However, nothing happened.

He frowned deeply and flicked the switch again. But once again, he was given the same result. A wave of panic washed over him as he stared into the darkness at the light switch.

No. He thought to himself. *No, there's no way.* He dove into his denial headfirst.

Katsuki attempted to walk calmly over to the next light switch, stumbling in the dark slightly. He felt it out on the smooth wall and flipped it too—but no light came. Katsuki gritted his teeth as he started erratically flipping the switch on and off. On and off, on and off, on and off, on and off, on and off, on and off—

"*Fuck*!" Katsuki yelled and slammed his fist next to the light switch, leaving a small dent.

He gazed around the darkness, and slowly his eyes adjusted to the blackness to see everything like dark television static surrounding him. There, he finally laid his eyes on his mother laying sadly on the living room ground. She was hunched over, leaning against their couch. Her head was tucked into her arms, and she was sobbing nearly mutely. As he grew closer, Katsuki could hear tiny little sobs. Sitting in his lap and scattered all around the living room rug were white envelopes.

Endless papers with red stamps and dollar signs.

Katsuki's heart sank when all the pieces fell into place.

He bent down slowly, face twisted in pure horror as he picked up one sheet. With shaky hands he clutched on to it. He read it, then clenched it so tightly his fingers tore through the page.

"Mom," Katsuki whispered. His voice was rocky. He tried to make it steady—but he couldn't. "I thought you said you were paying the bills?"

"I am," Mitsuki replied. "Th-The lights are just off for a little while because of building construction, sweetie. It's nothing you have to worry about! They'll be back soon. Why don't we go do your homework in the library tonight?"

Katsuki stared at her sideways and pain distorted his face. "*Don't.* Don't do that—don't fucking *lie* to me. I'm not a little kid anymore."

She lifted her head towards him, slightly dazed and he continued.

“I’ll ask again. Did you pay the bills, mom?” He repeated, a lot more forceful. He took a step forward and held up the crumpled piece of paper. “Tell me you’ve been paying the bills.”

“I have,” she murmured. Then her eyes averted. “I—I just may not have been paying *all* of them.”

“Mom, what the *fuck*—” Katsuki jeered, voice cracking on the end when his throat swelled with despair.

His eyes instantly became watery upon hearing those dreadful words. He clenched his jaw tight enough his mouth throbbed, attempting to hold in the clawing scream that was trapped in his throat. He held it in with all his will. Katsuki starred in denial as his mother who was weeping, spilling out endless apologies. Her tear-filled face was full of raw regret and hopelessness that hurt Katsuki to even look at.

All the questions he wanted to yell slammed against his closed mouth:

How could you be goddamn so irresponsible? How could you do this when you have a *child*? Was he not worth tending to? Was he not worth *feeding* and having a proper *home*? Why wasn’t he enough for her to love properly?

His young mind struggled to understand how she could let it get this bad.

But quickly, he buried all the blame that was burning in his body for her. He remembered his father’s last whisper once more and straightened out his back. Katsuki swallowed those heavy, unspoken questions. He let them sink to the bottom of his being like he was the dark sea, hoping to drown them out.

But he wasn’t aware at the time thoughts like those didn’t drown. They festered.

Young Katsuki took a look at his mother’s face. All he could see was grief. Her usually radiant features were darkened with the weight of living so much that he barely recognized her. He wondered if he ever felt grief like she was experiencing. Then he wondered, has he ever been given the opportunity to? But he didn’t have time to dwell on those thoughts now. He pushed back the stinging tears, refused to acknowledge his turmoil and sat down calmly.

“Let’s get this straightened out,” Katsuki whispered to himself.

One by one, he went through the endless sea of white letters.

He sorted them out with shaky hands. He organized out the ones that were coming up soon and the ones that were past due. He methodically structured it for himself and did the mental math. It was manageable. He could do this. He could get these paid. He just—

His hopes were crushed when he came across a particularly high bill. He swallowed when those stupid tears came rushing forward again. It was the rent bill and attached to it was a notice of eviction if failure to pay the full amount. Unbridled fear climbed into his body as he thought about the blistering winter against his skin. That one year of abandonment still haunted him.

He wearily glanced down to his tattered shoes. He studied the tiny blood droplets sprinkled on them.

Katsuki knew there would be no boy with green eyes this time.

“I can fix this,” Katsuki whispered. He gripped the piece of paper with deep determination. “We’ll catch up on the rent first. We can go without lights or electricity for a while, since we need the apartment to live in. But I need you to help mom, I need you to make sure to pay this if we can get the money. Alright?”

Tangible guilt rolled off his mother in tidal waves. There was internal blame clouding her eyes. She shook her head.

“Katsuki, this is nothing you should concern yourself with.”

“You’re right, it’s not,” Katsuki agreed sadly. He was too tired to be angry anymore. “But it’s something I *have* to concern myself with. You can’t do this by yourself. I’m old enough to see that.”

Mitsuki stayed silent for a long time. Katsuki observed in the dark room how all the emotions crashed like vicious surges across her face: guilt, sadness, and grief. He could even see longing and it was no question she was thinking of his father. Shame was the last emotion and her eyes shifted down to the floor.

“Okay,” Mitsuki whispered.

Katsuki’s fate was sealed that night, even if he didn’t know it.

☽ ☽ ☽

The following few days, Katsuki didn’t go to class. Instead, he wandered around their town begging for some sort of job, anything really. Fucking *anything*.

But there was only so much a thirteen-year-old could be qualified for. He begged the elder man who owned the grocery store to let him be a clerk. But the owner told him he needed to keep his head in the books on some bullshit wise-man advice. Katsuki gritted his teeth at that. He wouldn’t be able to even go to school if they were homeless again.

He tried to explain this to everyone he talked to—but thought he was trying to trick them. They gave the bullshit excuse that they had no job for someone as young as him. Kept saying his school would be a hindrance to their daily work schedules. But Katsuki persisted.

He looked for jobs in the sun. He looked for jobs in the rain. He did every single extras’ paper he got, even if it meant he didn’t turn in his own homework for a week. He sold his entire classical music collection, and his mother was surprisingly good about saving up money at work. She even sold some of her jewelry to help make ends meet.

Maybe the pressure of guilt was good for her, Katsuki decided.

Despite working in tandem to gather as much money as possible, they barely spoke. Maybe they both were too crunched, or maybe Katsuki couldn't stand the sight of her. He didn't want to grow to resent her. So, he averted his gaze for the benefit of their relationship. Katsuki promptly ignored the crying he could hear coming from the closed door at night. In return, his mother ignored his growling stomach when he left in the morning.

After a couple of weeks, the stress in his body had strung tightly like a violin chord. He was likely to snap at any moment.

Then it all peaked the day when it came time to pay the rent.

He had woken up, not knowing that this day would be different.

He put on his wrinkled school uniform, not bothering to put on a tie as he got dressed in the dark. The sun hadn't risen yet as he headed out to walk to school. He counted the stack of essays he stayed up all night writing, making sure he had all his orders in line. They would be able to pay the rent once he gathered the money today from his peers. It was barely scraping it, but he wouldn't have to worry about being homeless for at least a couple of months.

He gathered the money at school, and he despised the way all his peers' eyes looked through him. He could tell they all looked down at him with useless pity. Some of these kids were smart enough not to need their damn papers done, but word had spread through their school about how poor he was. He gritted his teeth when the top student of his class gave him money.

When Katsuki got home that day, he had to hold back tears once more.

He was fucking angry. He was so goddamn angry and *frustrated* with his whole life. But he didn't know *what* to do because he was *powerless*. He was trapped here—and part of him wished he had just run away with the boy with green eyes.

As Katsuki was fantasizing about that year in Tokyo, he walked up to the apartment. Out of reflex, he pulled out the shiny silver key to unlock the door but stopped when he saw it already cracked open. The darkness seeped out like spilled ink and no noise from inside could be heard.

He furrowed his brow, confused and alerted because his mother *never* left the door cracked open.

She was far too paranoid for that.

A shock of goosebumps crept up his spine to the nape of his neck.

He instantly took defense. He slotted his silver key between his fingers and tightened his hand into a fist. Katsuki's heart rate began to erratically speed up. He pushed open the door, peeking inside carefully. The hallway was dark but that wasn't out of the ordinary since they had been living without lights for so long.

But as he crept inside all the way, his stomach dropped out of his body. Standing there was a strange man in a full black suit with a neat, red tie and a gun.

The barrel was pressed directly against his mother's skull as he thumbed through all their hard-earned money.

Money they *needed*.

His mother had her arms up, shaking in deep fear that was more potent than he had ever seen radiating off her.

Mitsuki shook her head frantically. "*Please*, don't do this—"

"—A mark's a mark, ma'am." The stranger's voice was even and polite as he finished counting the money. "Not personal at all. The orders were either retrieve the cash from you or have the debt repaid in taking your life. This isn't nearly enough to even put a *dent* in the amount that was in the folder."

"P-Please. I have a *son*," his mother begged. "He's only thirteen, and he doesn't have any other family besides me. I can't leave him—I c-can't leave him by himself."

"You should have thought about that before you fled without repaying what you owed."

There was no emotion in the man's eyes. He shrugged as though he had seen a mother begging for her life frequently. He pocketed all their money for himself, cocked his gun and his eyes hardened with resolve.

In that split moment, Mitsuki's and Katsuki's gazes met. She wore a ghostly look of anticipating death. Pale. Uncertain. Desperate. This was an expression Katsuki would become familiar with in the years to come.

Within the second, Katsuki's body was triggered in flight or fight.

He chose to fight.

He charged forward, swinging his heavy backpack at the man the second before the trigger was pulled. The bullet redirected into the couch instead of his mother's skull with a sharp zing. Mitsuki flinched from the metal whizzing too close and covered her head with her arms.

The weight of the hard textbooks slammed against the man's skull with enough force to make him lose his balance. The man yelled in surprise, not sensing Katsuki's presence. He turned his gun quickly on Katsuki, but Katsuki's whole body dove into overdrive. With the sole thought of getting the money back, Katsuki kicked behind the man's knees, forcing him to buckle and tackled him.

It was a blur of grunts, his mother's cries, and the sharp whirring of stray bullets as they rolled around. Mitsuki's screeches in the background could be heard as Katsuki grappled for the gun. It wasn't until Katsuki had pinned the man down on the ground did silence grace

them. The man and Katsuki were in a gridlock of strength, attempting to gain control of the gun they both had a death grip on.

Young Katsuki's thoughts were frantic, erratic and pulsing with the desperate need to survive.

He *needed* his mother to live.

He *needed* to live.

They *needed* that money.

Katsuki's arms shook with adrenaline when the barrel of the gun started to be forced on him. Fear kicked up high and swallowed him. It was him or this man. Him and his mom or this man—

Within the next second, frightened Katsuki dug down deep inside his core.

He tapped into a searing anger that had been accumulating for years. It was molten hot. It pulsed with a litany of unforgiving whispers that demanded to make the world pay for how fucked up his life was. It wasn't fair. None of this was fucking *fair*. His sights locked on the man and the whispers shifted to screams telling him to make *this* man pay for what he was about to do.

Controlled by the deadly combination of anger and fear, Katsuki fully gripped on to this dark part of his mind. It gripped him back tenfold. The darkness gave a sharp, wicked grin that was hungry for pain and gifted him extra strength he had no idea he possessed.

Both the man and Mitsuki's eyes went wide when Katsuki let out a desperate yell. Within milliseconds, he started winning the test of strength. Mitsuki was screaming for him to stop, but Katsuki couldn't hear her. Before anyone could blink, Katsuki overpowered the man and turned the barrel on the man's forehead.

The man tried to crawl away, but Katsuki pulled the trigger.

The gunshot was quiet.

The silent bullet was the loudest thing Katsuki ever witnessed as it lodged between the man's eyes. Red blood splattered, painting across Katsuki's face. The large body went limp under him.

It didn't settle in right away.

The world stopped revolving as he took in all the small details. The metal gun in his hand was cold. The blood on his face was warm. His chest was heaving. His mother's yelling had stopped. The man's eyes were lifeless as he stared wide at the ceiling above them. Red liquid oozed out sluggishly onto their beige rug.

"Ka-Katsuki," Mitsuki whispered wearily. "*Katsuki*. You killed him."

Katsuki tore his eyes away from the man and glanced towards his mother.

In her hand was her phone and it was ready to dial the police. Her face was ghost pale in the dark, sunken with the weight of reality. She was trembling with fear with her hand over her mouth to stop the crying from leaking out. Her startled eyes darted between Katsuki, the gun, and the man on the ground. Katsuki followed her path of sight and the feeling of the gun in his hand suddenly was heavier than it truly was.

He looked down at the dead body underneath him and slowly shook his head in denial.

He killed someone.

He scrambled off the man, still in shock. He dropped the gun and swallowed.

When the body didn't move, what had happened settled in like a lump of scolding hot coals into his stomach.

That dark part of his core was rumbling in the shadows. Its malevolent grin was painted in scarlet as it filled his veins with satisfaction. He shook his head more, whispering to himself to snap out of it. As the adrenaline left his body, that depraved part of him faded away. It vanished back into the darkest part of his soul with a knowing smirk.

Katsuki was terrified to his bones. But he wasn't sure if he was horrified at how good he felt or horrified at the dead body. He knew the answer though, and the answer terrified him most.

He wondered if he should say sorry. Was he sorry? He searched his mind a while for this answer and found that he had no regrets.

"I-I was just trying to protect you," Katsuki reasoned.

That didn't make him a bad person, right? This man was hurting them. He was going to kill his mother and take her away from him—he couldn't have that happen *again*.

"You killed him," Mitsuki repeated in shock, as if trying to fully grasp the weight of what happened. She hadn't moved from her spot in the living room. "Katsuki—You *killed* him."

"But he was going to kill *you*," Katsuki hissed. He violently denied any guilt that tried to force its way in. He gestured wildly to the body on the ground. "Was I supposed to *let* him murder you?"

That snapped his mother out of her daze. She quickly hushed him and frantically ran to the door.

She appeared lost as she peered around, checking if anyone was nearby. There was terror etched into her face, aging her in appearance. She skittishly searched around the barren, empty hall. Katsuki knew she would find no one. Any neighbor they had was still at work. She locked the door tight and leaned against it and began to violently shake.

"I—I couldn't lose you too," Katsuki confessed. His face twisted in pain as he glanced between his mother's scared expression and the red blood seeping into their rug. Was she

afraid of him? “I couldn’t lose you *and* dad. I-I fucking can’t do it.”

He really thought he was going to cry at that moment. The tears felt like they were there, like a dull knife uselessly cutting through a solid surface. But they never came. His mother walked back towards him in the dark, and her shoulders squared out as she regarded the man on the ground.

“We…We have to hide the body tonight,” Mitsuki whispered after a long stretch of silence. “There’s woods several hours away.”

Katsuki was dumbfounded into speechlessness.

He didn’t know what he was expecting her to say but that wasn’t it.

“Hide the body?” He parroted to be sure. “We’re going to bury it?”

She gave him a gravely serious stare. Pointed, sharp.

“Yes, Katsuki. We’re going to bury it *extremely* deep,” Mitsuki whispered. The edge in her voice was unfamiliar but it seemed as though she had navigated this type of darkness in a previous life. “You can go to *jail* for murder, it doesn’t matter if you’re a minor. You would go away for a minimum five years and I—” Her eyes softened. “I-I can’t lose you either. So, we have to pretend this *never* happened. We’re packing tonight and getting out of here immediately.”

Katsuki nodded slowly, realizing that yes, he had committed an extreme crime.

His mother straightened out her back and took in a deep breath. Her face was shrewd, serious like he had never seen. She nearly felt mechanical, like she had done this before as she moved through the motions. She hurried and rushed into the bathroom, leaving Katsuki alone with the bloody body on the ground.

He stared at it, studying the man’s slightly aged face for the first time.

It was then that Katsuki felt a trickle of guilt. The man suddenly seemed more human than threat now. He concluded the man was in his late thirties, like his father was right before he died. The nameless man’s skin was even pale with chocolate brunette hair the same as his father’s. The comparison made Katsuki ponder if this man had kids at home that would be fatherless just like he was.

Suddenly, the reach of a single human life was apparent to Katsuki.

He realized that this man might have friends and family that would miss him. People who loved him dearly and probably looked forward to spending time with him. He wondered what his laugh sounded like or what his favorite dish to cook was. He wondered if he brought his partner flowers on the weekend and if they did romantic dinner nights together.

But now, Katsuki had made sure none of that would ever occur again.

When his mother came back to the living room, in her arms was an array of cleaning supplies. She snapped on purple, rubber gloves with a fierce determined expression and tossed Katsuki a pair.

“Follow my lead, Katsuki. We’re scrubbing this place clean.”

Katsuki put the gloves on and listened carefully to his mother’s instructions.

☽ ☽ ☽

Later that evening in the darkest of night, he and his mother spent quality time together for the first time in years.

He hated how he appreciated it. It was one of the few instances her eyes looked at him without underlying shame. And it was the first time he looked at her without feeling a simmering anger. They were united in bloodshed now, and Katsuki could feel that burden carve its way into his skin.

The mother and son dug a hole six feet in the ground side by side. They stole shovels from some family’s backyard on the drive up. No words were exchanged as they dug into the cold ground. The moon was the only witness to their act. Every sling of the shovel made reality dig its sharp claws in further. By the end, he was covered in dirt and the tiny area under his fingernails were caked with soil and dried blood.

When they lifted the body, it had been bleeding a bit still. It leaked all over him, covering him in a reminder that *he* spilled this blood and that this was *his* doing.

The smell of iron shook him a bit, and he stood still looking down at the lifeless face of the man. Staring back at him were phantoms of his imagination that he thought might be this man’s mother, daughter, or son. He could see them crying over this. He wondered if they would feel the same empty void Katsuki felt when his father died.

When he failed to move, his mother harshly whispered his name. She snapped her dirt covered fingers in his face and ordered him to quickly get a move on. They swung the body into the deep hole and began to fill it back up. The heavy load of dirt strained his arms, reminding him exactly the weight of his foul deed. He tried to make it look as inconspicuous as possible, caking the dirt on top with leaves. Then his mother blurred the edges of the hole to make it seem like that land hadn’t been disturbed.

He wondered how she knew to do that.

“C’mon,” Mitsuki said while grabbing the shovels. She jutted her head towards their car urgently. “The sun is coming up and we need to go *now*.”

Katsuki nodded, but as she walked away he stood there for a moment.

He looked down at his hands.

They were coated with deep, scarlet for the first time.

☽ ☽ ☽

He wondered if he should feel regret.

This was the part where he should be overcome with guilt, worry and paranoia he assumed. They had buried a man without so much as a real tear shed. He should have felt something—but his emotions were entirely blank. He knew this was because he thought the scummy man deserved it. The stranger had nearly separated him from his mom and after what he went through, he would kill anyone who tried to even fucking think about that.

He wondered what was going through his mom's head though.

She was chewing on the inside of her cheek, clearly worried. However, she was calmer than someone who had witnessed their son murdering in cold blood should be. In fact, she barely showed any remorse about it.

It almost was as if she was reliving a past life.

The car ride after they buried the man was quiet and filled with static radio. The pop song that played in the speakers of their run-down car was coated with white noise as he looked at his mother's wedding ring. The once shiny diamond was caked with dirt and blood. It seemed so wrong to have such a precious remembrance of his father's love covered in filth.

But then his eyes glanced up towards the shiny pearls around her slender neck. He frowned when a gnawing apprehension settled in his gut. He glanced at their back seat full of suitcases and trash bags. All the bags had been frantically packed to the brim with their things. Which wasn't exactly a lot, but he curiously stared at those pearls once more.

"That man said you owed money," Katsuki spoke over the static noise. "Why do you owe money to someone?"

Mitsuki stiffened. Tension wrapped around her shoulders and her grip tightened on the wheel.

"Because I fucked up," Mitsuki admitted, tiredly. "I owe it to you to be truthful from here on out. I gambled with the wrong crowd for a while, Katsuki. I thought they had forgotten about me because it's been years, but—I was clearly wrong."

He should be more surprised. But as he thought about the strange people his mother always had in and out growing up, he wasn't. In fact, he was numb to his core. He stared at her blankly, and all his mind could focus on was the future and keeping them safe—like he always was.

"So, what does this mean for us?" Katsuki asked.

Mitsuki's eyes hardened. "It means we keep it moving,"

☽ ☽ ☽

True to his mother's word, they did.

It felt silly, all that work he did to make sure they didn't get evicted and they had left the apartment anyways. They had enough funds to live out of various nicotine smelling hotel rooms for a while. During this time, they sorted out their lives. His mother was carefully considering where to go next, mentioning all the places she had gambled.

When he tried to ask who would want to have her murdered for debts, she seemed unsure. That alone made Katsuki weary.

How the fuck did she not *know*?

"It should be simple," Katsuki hissed. "Who the hell did you gamble with so much that they want you *killed* for not paying them back?" This was fucking ridiculous.

"Look, I made a lot of fucking mistakes up before I had you," Mitsuki muttered, rolling her eyes. "I gambled a lot. Drank more than I do. I even dated a lot of not-so-great people before I met your father. It could be anyone and I didn't exactly keep a goddamn notebook of all the shit I owed, alright?"

She lit a cigarette nonchalantly. Her fingers trembled with stress and her face was tugged into a deep frown. The fire of the lighter danced enchantingly, but it was haunting in the same breath. Katsuki had never seen her smoke before, yet it was fitting like a missing jigsaw piece.

As they bounced from hotel to hotel, he found out who his mother really was.

She had always been sweet to him, but after the murder that demeanor faded like a memory of the past. She was still herself at her core, but she treated him a lot less like a child now—which meant she cursed more, did a lot more vulgar things and stopped regarding him like her soft naive boy.

Now, she regarded him like a man who was capable of murder.

She didn't bother filtering herself. She cursed like a sailor, and he found out she was hiding her abrasiveness from him up until now.

One time, they had gone to the grocery store and Katsuki mentioned he wanted a specific snack. The store was sold out, but when they were in line to check out the person in front of them had several bags of the chips. His mother lifted them from the man's cart. This proceeded to make a scene and ignited a huge argument which he found his mother won. She had made the random man cry, lied about him coming on to her to security and then commented on the poor man's weight and his balding pattern.

Katsuki felt icky when he was handed the chips in their tiny hotel room. But when he showed that bit of disgust by her actions, she called him a punk and complained that he shouldn't have whined about wanting them then. After that, he ate them in bitter silence.

By the time they found somewhere new to settle more permanently, it was far away from the countryside.

Osaka.

It was bright, lively, and full of life that was absent from the slow pace of their previous home. They were back in the city, blending in with the large crowds. It reminded young Katsuki of Tokyo in a painful way.

He sometimes thought he saw the ghost of the boy with green eyes in the streets. Phantom memories of those big, doe eyes followed him as they walked through the sea of people. This caused him to whirl around frantically, eyes darting to check all the unfamiliar faces. He desperately searched for that single hint of green.

But it was all in his imagination.

It hurt him deeply every time this happened—like an illusion shattering over and over until the jagged pieces were nothing but tiny speckles on the ground. When the edges were too painful to piece together again, he decided again to bury it and stop.

No more green eyes. No more saviors.

He was his own savior, and he had to be his mother's.

☽ ☽ ☽

A year passed by with no occurrences and for once in Katsuki's life, it seemed like things were mildly okay again. Hell, maybe they would remain this way?

The murder was swept under the metaphoric rug like broke pieces of a vase he had smashed. His mother treated it that way too, like a simple childish mistake that she could ignore by pushing it as far out of sight as possible. They barely spoke of it, and the man's gun was locked away in their new safe.

But sometimes she carried it around with her in the house for 'protection' or whatever.

He was enrolled in school again, and the city kids were a lot different. They barely paid him the time of day. No one bothered to make fun of him, or even tried. Instead, they kept with their friends and paid attention to their studies. Some people greeted him but mostly, he was just another face in the crowd—no one really worth remembering.

He was okay with that after what he had done.

His mother was getting her act together again. But Katsuki squinted at this a bit, hesitant to believe her change of pace after what occurred last time. She found a new job working at a fancy office building downtown and was making significantly more money. She seemed more stable now, happier. She was openly her vulgar self, giving him the office gossip without filtering herself every night during dinner.

What was strange though was that his mother stayed in the apartment most of the time now.

Their new home wasn't special.

In fact, it was cramped and a little too tight for two people. But it was cozier than the last place, and his mother gave some effort to make it a home. More food. More furniture and decor around the small space. They even had spent a night abstract painting on two canvases together. Katsuki had liked this day, and they hung up their paintings on the wall side by side. Everything was given to him with a smile and a pat on the head. Then every night, she sat on the couch smoking through a pack of cigarettes watching TV.

She never bothered to talk to strange men anymore and properly paid the bills. She tried to tell Katsuki he didn't have to worry anymore about money, but he did. He was fourteen now and Katsuki couldn't tell if this was because she was attempting to straighten out again or if she was afraid someone might recognize her if she went out.

But no matter what the real answer to that question was, Katsuki found out the latter to be true.

When he came back from school one evening, it was quiet just like it had been that fateful day of his first murder. The hallway lights were flickering, and he had been so distracted. He wondered if it would have changed anything to notice the man cloaked in black trailing behind him. Looking back on it, Katsuki knew it was a useless thought.

Especially when he got to their apartment door and the feeling of cold steel pressed against the back of his skull. His blood ran cold as winter, filling him with dread all the way down to his bones.

"Open the door quietly and I won't shoot," a smooth, even voice demanded. "Scream and I'll blow your brains out, kid."

Katsuki did as he was told, gritting his teeth. He tried to harden his nerves and breathe calmly, but he couldn't. His intakes were sharp, forced, and his hands were unsteady as he unlocked the door. He walked in and the loud sound of a vacuum covered up him and the mysterious man's entrance.

His mom was playing one of his old vinyl records, smoking, and humming loudly over the sound of the vacuum. Katsuki wanted to try to warn her of danger, but he knew that would set the man off. So, he did the next best thing.

"Hey mom, I had a great day at school."

His mother stopped in her tracks, took her cigarette out of her mouth and frowned.

"*Hah*? Why the fuck do you sound so polite suddenly? You hate school—"

Her words ran dry when she turned and saw the sight of Katsuki being held at gunpoint.

Her reaction was quicker than he thought it would be. His mother quickly drew the stolen gun from a pocket in her frilly apron and aimed it very precisely at the man and her face twisted in a scowl.

"Let him go or I'll blow your goddamn ear off," Mitsuki threatened.

The man shifted the barrel of the gun into Katsuki's temple and Katsuki's breath hitched in fear.

"Shoot and I kill your son, Bakugou Mitsuki." His voice was level, and unafraid. In fact, he nearly sounded fucking tired like he was on a bad vacation. "I know who you are, and I know *exactly* who you're in debt with."

That seemed to waiver his mother a bit, but only a bit.

"Not until you take the gun of my fucking son's head," Mitsuki demanded. "You lay a finger on him and I'm killing both you and me. I don't give a shit."

The man let out a long sigh and shook his head. "We both know that's not how this works. Put your gun down and we can talk further, Mitsuki. I'm not here to hurt you. I want to negotiate with you."

Consideration trickled into his mother's features while fear trickled into Katsuki. He worried it was a damn lie, to lure her into putting her guard down—and she did. She lowered the gun when she glanced at Katsuki's terrified eyes.

"Fine," Mitsuki said reluctantly. She pointed the gun to the floor with sadness in her eyes. "Now let my son go. Leave him out of this, *please*."

The begging nature of her voice was sad.

He didn't want her to fucking beg.

The adult man grunted as a response then pushed him forward like he was a sack of fucking nothing. Katsuki fell to his knees harshly and he glared up at the man angrily.

But upon laying his sights on him, he stumbled a bit, caught off guard. The man's appearance was not what he was expecting. He was dressed in a similar black suit as the first man who had barged into their life. But instead of a red tie the man wore a shimmering black one that was laced with silver designs.

His face looked perpetually tired, the dark circles under his eyes resembled murky windows to the horrors in the world he had seen. His hair was silky, pitch black and it fell gracefully to his shoulders, slightly grazing his blazer's pads.

The man observed Katsuki carefully, and his finger was fiddling with the trigger of his gun. What was most curious though, he didn't turn his weapon on Mitsuki. Maybe the man was smart—the last person to aim a gun at his mother wound up six feet underground.

"We haven't met before, my name is Aizawa," the man said, surprising Katsuki. He bowed at the waist. "I'm sure you know exactly why I am here, Mitsuki."

"To collect money for some unknown gangster I can't remember?" Mitsuki sneered. "Can you please leave me alone? I swear I don't recall who I owed the money to. Can I set up some sort of payment plan and move on with my life?"

“Actually, the debt is only part of the reason I’m here,” Aizawa admitted. “Part because of the debt collection, the other part because it seems like the person I had sent *originally* is missing—and you have his gun I am noticing.”

They both froze.

Katsuki could feel the consequences of his actions running full speed to catch up with him. Aizawa glanced between Mitsuki and Katsuki before continuing. His eyes turned icy, and goosebumps ran up Katsuki’s arms.

“I’m afraid this is no longer simply a matter of *money*,” Aizawa said a lot less kindly. His eyes hardened and he frowned in disgust. “You murdered one of my men and I don’t take kindly to that a single bit. I believe in blood for blood when it comes to that, the money be damned.”

The tone shift was so startlingly drastic it threw everyone off. The man named Aizawa lifted his gun, ready to fire but Katsuki yelled before he could pull the trigger.

“I killed him you fucking bastard!” Katsuki screamed.

Both adults froze and turned their sights onto the shaking teen.

This was the first time Katsuki had said it out loud. He curled his fists so tightly until pain sparked from his nails digging into his palms.

“I killed him,” Katsuki whispered a lot softer. His heart pulsed rapidly, and his body strung tight with self-hatred. But he told himself he didn’t regret it. “If you’re going to repay the blood anywhere, do it with me.”

Aizawa, if that was even his real name, seemed too stunned to speak.

The man’s sharp, dangerous eyes cut to Mitsuki who was staring at Katsuki in shock, harshly whispering for him to shut up and not say another word.

“You killed him?” Aizawa repeated in disbelief. “But you’re just a kid.”

“I’m not a damn kid,” Katsuki shot back. He stood up, aware of his height for the first time in a while. He hadn’t realized he had gotten bigger a bit, but now the growing pains were evident deep in his quaking bones. “I killed him and I’ll fucking do it again. I’ll kill you too if you so much as lay a finger on her.”

He leered maliciously, ready to commit that foul act once more. He started plotting ways to grab the man’s gun, bash his head in and paint him fucking red in the same manner he had done the other suited bastard.

That dark part of him reared a tiny bit, rumbling at the prospect of bloodshed.

“*Relax*,” Aizawa mumbled. He cracked his neck tiredly and—

—walked straight past Katsuki?

Katsuki frowned, puzzled and whipped his head around to follow the man's movements. Aizawa's walk was lethargic, and he carded his hand through his silky hair tiredly. As he passed Mitsuki, his mother lifted her gun as well, ready to pull it at any slight ill intent—but Aizawa simply patted her shoulder like a friend and sat down on their couch.

Aizawa loosened his tie from around his neck and let out a loud, exasperated exhale. A million thoughts were running in his head no doubt. Just when Aizawa looked like he was at peak stress, his eyes sparked with life at the sight of the tea set on the table. He placed his gun down with a clunk and began pouring himself a cup of tea.

Katsuki and Mitsuki exchanged confused glances.

"Well, this changes things a lot." Aizawa sighed and took a long sip of the hot liquid in the tiny cup. He scratched at his chin stubble in contemplation. "This is much more complicated than I expected."

"Are you drinking my goddamn tea?" Mitsuki muttered, baffled.

"Yes I am. I have a headache right now, ma'am," Aizawa cut down sharply. His blood shot eyes bored into Mitsuki unfazed. "There's a lot going on in my life right now. Work is killing me, I just got diagnosed with sciatica, and I found a bundle of gray hair yesterday. To make matters somehow worse, you, your brat, and my dead colleague are an extra headache on top of everything. So, a nice cup of tea is helpful because I don't exactly know where my head is at."

"You just had a gun on me a second ago ready to blow my head off. That very much seemed like you knew where your *head was at.*"

"Yeah, well, I thought you had killed my friend," Aizawa quipped. "I have a policy that if a man of mine dies on the job, I kill whoever did it. Debts or not. But—" He gave a low, exhausted groan and scratched his chin again. He cut his gaze to Katsuki. "I also have a moral code of not killing kids. All that shit about children being our future and their potential."

Katsuki bristled. "I *said* I'm not a—"

"—Just shut up," Aizawa jeered. He pinched the bridge of his nose and shook his head. "Please. Shut up. You're clearly no older than sixteen."

"I'm fourteen," Katsuki corrected.

Aizawa made a disgruntled face, gawking at Katsuki even more distressed. "That's *worse*."

Aizawa groaned loudly and ran his hands down his face. He started mumbling under his breath, tiny bits of words Katsuki could only partially catch. Then suddenly, he straightened his back and looked like he had come up with a brilliant plan that was bound to make him the most exhausted man in the world.

“Okay, I’ll be blunt with you, Mitsuki,” Aizawa said. He folded his hands and pressed his lips into an unimpressed, thin line. “You owe 11,499,850 yen to Imasuji Goto aka Muscular aka one of the biggest gambling gangsters from Sapporo. Ring a bell?”

“N-No,” Mitsuki whispered. Katsuki frowned at the stutter as his mother’s eyes glanced everywhere *but* him. “I’ve never heard of that man before.”

“Well, he’s heard of you,” Aizawa shot back. He took another long sip of tea. “He says you’ve been owing him for about—”

He looked Katsuki up and down. He studied his blond hair carefully and his face. Aizawa squinted his eyes and raised an eyebrow.

“…Fifteen years now,” Aizawa said suspiciously. “But it seems like you’re very slippery. Always moving around. Got married, your last name changed, and you disappeared until last year when someone mentioned you in the underground gambling scene in the countryside.”

Mitsuki didn’t say a word.

Katsuki frowned deeply hearing this—but he told himself his mother had been honest. She said she had been involved with shady people. At least now they knew *who* was hunting her down.

Aizawa sipped his tea and then turned to Mitsuki again. “Long story short, he put a hit out on you.”

Mitsuki’s eyes went wide, and she staggered backwards. “W-What, a *hit*? As in, *kill* me?!”

“Kill you and bring back a piece of your body as the evidence,” Aizawa amended. Katsuki felt like he was going to be sick. “Muscular takes his work very seriously, I’m sure you know. But that’s where I come in, and the man you killed. Whose name is Asahi by the way—if you care. He has a daughter who has been crying for her missing father for a year now.”

“I don’t care,” Katsuki cut in. “She can keep fucking crying. And I’ll bury you next to your goddamn sorry ass friend if you try to kill *my* mother.”

He looked at Aizawa nastily, keeping a close eye pinned to the gun on the table. Aizawa frowned at Katsuki’s sudden answer, clearly finding it concerning. He cocked his head at the young boy and sipped his tea slowly.

“…Noted,” Aizawa drawled. “But, I’m here because I’m from the company hired to kill you. It’s nothing personal, it’s just my job. The assignment was to either get you to pay the debt in full or have your head brought to him.”

The silence prickled at Katsuki’s skin. His heart slowed with sadness when he realized there was no end to this.

That gangster would keep coming after his mother over and over again until they had the money or if she was dead. It would be a never-ending cycle and they would have to keep moving and moving and moving and moving—

“I…I can’t pay that,” Mitsuki whispered. Her eyes were watery, and her shoulders were shaking. “Can—Can you work up a payment plan or something with him?”

“I’m sorry, but he doesn’t have payment plans. You know this,” Aizawa said. He looked at Katsuki with pity. “But, I can make an exception and try to find a way to help you out of this situation. For your son’s sake.”

Mitsuki’s eyes sparked with life. “Th-Thank you! Thank you so much! What do I have to do?”

“Have your son work off the debts with me. Since he killed my colleague, I’ll call it even if he does. He can work and get enough money to pay off Muscular in about a couple of months. I’ll tell Muscular I couldn’t find you and when I did, you had the money. All this will be erased.”

“*What*?!” Mitsuki hissed, jerking away. She shook her head harshly and her lip curled in disgust. “He’s not going to kill people for you.”

“He’s *already* killed someone,” Aizawa pointed out. “And he seems more than ready to do it again if I make the wrong move right now. But it’ll be mostly body guarding and assisting with tasks.”

“No, I fucking refuse. I’ll find a way to work for the money—”

“—I’ll do it,” Katsuki interrupted.

Both adults’ eyes whirled towards him. Aizawa was curious, his mother was stunned.

Katsuki had been standing there, listening carefully. His face was blankly staring at the delicate design of the porcelain teacups on the table.

He weighed out all his options and he knew deep down this was the best route. This man might’ve been a bastard, but he was a bastard who was willing to help them out. And what was the fucking alternative? His mother would never save up that much money, she was too irresponsible. They would have to keep moving and moving repeatedly until maybe one day someone cut off her head.

Then he would truly be alone.

“Katsuki, *no*,” Mitsuki quickly rejected. She walked up to him and grabbed his shoulders. “This isn’t for you. You’re a good kid.”

“It’s temporary,” Katsuki reasoned. He refused to meet her gaze, unsure if he could stomach the look of worry on her face. He shouldn’t be doing this, but he *had* to. He fucking had to suck it up if he wanted any lick of stability in his life because his mother was unable to give it to him. “We’ll pay off the money and then things will be normal afterwards.”

His mother’s face twisted with uncertainty. Words were teetering on her tongue and shadows of her unknown past danced in her eyes.

“Fine,” Mitsuki eventually conceded, shamefully. She turned away from Katsuki and glared at Aizawa who was pouring himself a second cup of tea. “But he doesn’t go near Imasuji Goto. That man can’t know what he looks like. You hear me? I’ll kill you if you let that man near him.”

Katsuki wanted to ask why but Aizawa seemed to take whatever hint his mother dropped.

“I’ll make sure of it, don’t worry,” Aizawa said seriously. “He’s in safe hands with me.”

“So, when do I start?” Katsuki muttered.

Aizawa stood up, quickly downed his second cup of tea and tucked his gun in his holster. He looked at Katsuki very seriously.

“Today.”

☽ ☽ ☽

Working for Aizawa was a fucking *experience*.

Katsuki was being run ragged by this man, but the worst part is that he treated him like a fucking *kid*. But he wasn’t a goddamn kid and he wished this snarky, weirdly tired bastard understood that. Every chance Aizawa got, he reminded Katsuki of his age, like it was on purpose.

“Hey, kid. Go grab me a cup of coffee.”

“Watch your mouth, kid. I’m more than twice your age and I have killed more people than how old you are.”

“I remember when I was your age. I was a lot less of a headache—but I remember. Good times.”

It drove Katsuki up a goddamn *wall*.

But, deep down he was thankful for the opportunity to work off his mother’s debts. This meant they could have a normal life soon.

After this he could go on like nothing happened and they could *stay* in Osaka. He could have his forever home that he dreamed of and always wanted with his mother. The kind of home he saw people have an attachment to in movies. While the small apartment wasn’t exactly a shining property with a back yard and pretty fence, it was probably the closest to it he’d ever come.

Katsuki desperately wanted that glimmering hope of a future.

As the months went on, Katsuki realized Aizawa truly didn’t even make him work that much. Or at least in Katsuki’s opinion. He was witness to some terrible shit, but really he felt like he was just there as an accessory or a favor. The tired hitman man really just had him follow him

around to these vague, weird places with seedy men. He gave Katsuki a gun and shooting lessons.

“If someone seems suspicious while I’m making out deals, shoot them in their kneecaps,” Aizawa instructed on the first day on the job. “Don’t hesitate. Trust your gut.”

He taught Katsuki everything he needed to know. Specifically, about how to take someone down and make them feel just enough pain to regret stepping out of line. But he never taught him how to kill.

Which made that small, inkling of darkness inside of Katsuki restless. That side of him flickered around the new danger. It whispered to him that he wanted to taste and grasp the curious act of killing.

That side of him grew louder every day when he quickly learned Aizawa murdered for a living. Specifically, Aizawa took requests on who he was to kill for large sums of money for some secretive company. Aizawa made Katsuki stand like a watchdog behind him in his dusty office as he did these deals in Osaka. But it was mostly pointless. Aizawa could handle himself far more well than Katsuki could ever really help. That man was somehow *always* fucking tired but deadly like one of the most trained killers alive.

He was given an example of this fully when some shady man tried to pull one over on him, lying about the job at hand. Aizawa lazily strummed his fingers on his expensive mahogany table and then grabbed the shotgun that was sitting discreetly under his desk.

“Get out of my office,” Aizawa had said without any tone inflection. He cocked the weapon and pointed it directly between the man’s eyes. “I’m going to count to three, and you better be out of the building when I finish. *One*—”

Katsuki had never seen someone move so fast.

A part of Katsuki bitterly admired the old man. He was actually…*really* fucking cool.

Every day he paid Katsuki for his ‘bodyguard’ services which was a hell of a lot more yen than he ever expected. He even treated him out for dinners and lunches and started telling him how to properly fix his hair. While spending all this time with Aizawa, Katsuki even learned how to properly do his school tie. Katsuki didn’t realize he never actually knew how to do it until that day his crooked, lopsided tie was pointed out. Sometimes Aizawa even asked him about his day at school, or if he had any friends. Those questions caught him off guard the most. No one in Katsuki’s life asked about *him*.

It was a type of attention Katsuki hadn’t received in years. It was close to feeling like how Katsuki imagined family to be at a certain point.

Every day, Katsuki wanted to run home to his mom and gloat about how much cash he was able to get—it was all the money he always dreamed and cried over. But sometimes when he came home that wind of joy was snatched from his lungs.

His mom was slipping again.

It was subtle, but he could see that familiar look of instability in her worn-down eyes. She chain smoked and the smell of nicotine was now clinging to his clothes. The food in the fridge was thinning again, and she stopped asking to help him with his homework. She began to grow lethargic, and he noted some days she didn't go to work. The phone would ring and ring, but she couldn't answer it.

She looked skittish ever since the mention of that gangster, Imasuji Goto. Sometimes Katsuki caught her staring at him, studying his face underneath their pale kitchen lights. Then some days, his mother couldn't look at him. She would keep her eyes averted to the ground when they conversed and part of that really fucking *hurt*.

Katsuki concluded whoever that man was, the mere mention of his name triggered something terrible in his mother.

Out of fear that she might mess this glimmer of a future up, Katsuki decided to tell Aizawa to keep the money on himself. The elder man seemed a little shocked by this, but he did as Katsuki requested.

Katsuki wearily started realizing that while he loved his mother, she was never going to be capable of being someone to lean on. His heart had broken one day when she had promised to take him to the carnival, and she was too drunk to even get out of the house. He concluded that maybe it was him, he wasn't good enough to be her son and there would always be that barrier between them.

After all, she had witnessed him murder someone.

There was something in her eyes after that day, something she wasn't telling him.

But she sometimes looked at him with fear.

☽ ☽ ☽

One day after months of obscure jobs, skipping school, and trying his best to comfort his mother, Aizawa asked him to come with him to Yokohama for a month. At first his mother objected, clearly not a fan of the idea of Katsuki away, but Aizawa reassured that this was the last leg of his work haul.

Yokohama was beautiful, Katsuki thought upon arrival. It was a pretty city that had shining glass skyscrapers that climbed up to the sky like deities watching over the crowd of citizens. It warmed him in a strange way as the summer wind caressed him welcomingly.

Aizawa paid for him to be in a nice hotel near the secretive office that was conveniently placed downtown. The hotel was the nicest place Katsuki had ever stayed. It had multiple rooms, a fully functioning kitchen and a stainless-steel fridge.

But what caused him the most shock was the fact Aizawa had filled the fridge *up*. Endless piles of food were stacked inside and most of it was his favorites.

Has that old man realized what foods he liked these last five months?

After unpacking, Katsuki plopped down on the leather couch and kicked his legs up. As he stared over the lavish cityscape, Katsuki realized he could get used to this. He ate his favorite snack on the comfy couch and turned on the large flat screen TV.

It hurt a bit, that this would probably be the only chance he could afford to live this type of lifestyle until he was old enough to get a real job. But even after that—would he be able to? He furrowed his brows. Who's to say his mother would dig them in another ditch? Would he even be able to leave her alone to go to college? Quickly, the future felt short sighted. When he thought of his mother, his options for life were far more limited because of what a wild card she was.

Hell, when Katsuki even considered it, he wasn't actually sure what he wanted to do anymore.

When he was younger he wanted to compose classical music like those fancy people. But… could he do that? Didn't that require money? *School*? He had looked it up and most people who succeeded in music took lessons young. Katsuki was already fourteen and he didn't even know how to read sheet music. He looked it up on his phone, and suddenly he was overwhelmed by the different kinds of notes.

That looney old man had never shown him how to read music. Just taught him fancy phrases like crescendo—but what was a crescendo in terms of sheet music? The black symbols on his phone screen might as well been a foreign language.

He had never thought about his future this much in depth.

Up until recently, his mind was like a barren, dark road. He couldn't see part down his path or even see what lied at the end. He could only see as far as the first few streetlights reached. But now, with money and Aizawa, more streetlights had flickered on. He could see a bit further—but he still didn't know what was at the end.

A small seed of confusion planted inside of him.

☽ ☽ ☽

At the end of the time in Yokohama, Aizawa took him to his headquarters.

They walked up to a super fancy looking building but instead of walking through the front, they entered through a side door. It made Katsuki flat out baffled because it was a regular store. No better place than to hide in plain sight, Katsuki figured.

He quickly learned the building was a disguise. The store they walked into was labeled 'Cleaning Services', ironically. Even had a stupid little kawaii washing machine icon that was blushing. Katsuki made a face of disgust at the cuteness and when they walked in it seemed like a normal, everyday laundry mat.

People were washing their clothes, but when Katsuki looked closer, those clothes had blood stains.

Aizawa walked straight to the back door and gave five, very rhythm specific knocks.

Some woman dressed in a stylish, white pants suit with long platinum blonde hair answered the door. She had pretty pecan colored skin and sharp carmine eyes. She tilted her head unimpressed at Aizawa upon their arrival and glared at Katsuki up and down. Suddenly, Katsuki was a little self-conscious of his shabby throw away clothes. He stared down at his shotty button up shirt that was wrinkled and the odd stain that was on it. Heat rushed to his face when he realized how nicely Aizawa and this woman were dressed.

“Is this the punk who killed Asahi?” The woman asked sourly. She tilted her head when she looked at Katsuki’s face closely. “Wait. He looks like—”

“—Yeah, this is the headache,” Aizawa cut off quickly. He lazily waved a hand between them. “Katsuki, this is Miruko. Miruko, this is Katsuki. He’s the *special* case I had mentioned over the phone. Remember?”

The woman now identified as Miruko blinked then scoffed. She rolled her eyes and stepped aside for them to walk into the hidden door. “Come on in, kid.”

Upon entry, Katsuki couldn’t stop the low whistle that slipped out of him.

“Holy *shit*,” he muttered, wide eyed.

This place was first class rich. These motherfuckers had more money than he ever could comprehend and all of it came from what—fucking *murder*?

As they walked through the building, Katsuki couldn’t help but gawk. It was a luxe office space that smelled like crisp perfumes and subtle rich colognes. The floors were gray marble, and the walls were painted black with silver trimming. There were people bustling all about in suits and fancy business clothes. They were laughing with folders in their hands. Some green. Some red. Some yellow and curiously some colored black, but those were few.

Other individuals walked by dressed in all black with ski masks and loaded guns. One woman even walked by casually on the phone as she sharpened a set of knives.

They walked past a lobby that had a giant ‘C’ embossed into the black wall. Miruko led them to a hallway full of shining silver elevators and swiped an ID card that was hanging around her neck. The two adults chatted casually, and Katsuki could tell they were good friends.

They rode the elevator up, and Katsuki liked how fancy it all was. By the time they reached the top floor, they came to Aizawa’s *real* office, he learned. This time, the room was way larger and the open window view over Yokohama was stunning. Aizawa walked over to his endless black file cabinets and unlocked a specific drawer. As he did this, Katsuki sauntered up to the wall that was nothing but glass and peered down. He felt tall up here, bigger and like he was someone important for once.

As Katsuki turned around, he caught the sight of Aizawa’s desk. Sitting on top of it was an old photo in a golden frame that seemed like it was recently polished. The photo was old, worn and cracked in places to show the white of the material through the happy photo. There

was a tear right down the middle between Aizawa and someone who was a young teen who looked incredibly like him.

Being the nosy person he was, Katsuki picked up the frame.

“Who is this?” Katsuki asked. “He’s got your weird ass nose.”

Aizawa stopped rummaging through the cabinets a bit to turn to him. He only spared a split-second glance before turning around. His shoulders grew tense as he thumbed through files.

“That’s my son,” Aizawa said distantly. “His name was Koji.”

Katsuki froze. “Was?”

“He died. About seven years ago.”

Scarlet eyes studied the photograph and the man in the room with him a bit closer upon hearing this information. The father-son duo appeared happy in the snippet of the past. But there was a large burning curiosity in Katsuki that wanted to ask what had happened. But he bit his tongue when he could feel the sullen aura droop off of the usually unbothered man.

Aizawa took out a folder after his long search, signed a couple of dotted lines and handed it over to him.

Katsuki looked down at the flimsy piece of paper curiously and Aizawa smiled at him for the first time ever.

“You’re officially debt free, kid. Or at least your mother is.” There was a twinge of distaste in that statement. “I delivered the money to Muscular yesterday, and the slate is wiped clean.”

Katsuki stood there, stunned a bit. Six months had passed by so quickly he hadn’t even noticed—especially this last month while he was living in the nice hotel. Somewhere down the line, he stopped tallying the money as he got to know Aizawa better. Gradually, Katsuki placed down the photograph. Looking between Koji and Aizawa carefully.

“Right,” Katsuki said. He cleared his throat. “Uh, thank you. For making an exception for me and my mother.”

“It’s not a problem. Don’t mention this—*ever*. I’m serious. This is not a joke.”

The hint of humor in the sentence made Katsuki laugh slightly, he was going to miss the strange sarcastic nature of this man.

“Of course. I will never talk about this ever again.”

Truthfully, Katsuki didn’t know how to behave. For once, he felt awkward in his own skin. He stared down at the contract that was a signed copy of his release from debt. It felt odd, all his troubles and turmoil boiled down to this simple white paper with black ink and some numbers.

He reached for it and tried to grab it, but when he tugged, Aizawa didn't let go.

Katsuki frowned and glared at Aizawa.

"What are you doing, old man?" Katsuki muttered.

"Can I give you some advice, kid?" Aizawa pressed. His voice was no longer warm, but sharp and full of edge.

Katsuki didn't respond, only glared at him impatiently.

"It's better to jump off a ship that is heading to crash and take your chances with the sea," Aizawa said seriously. His dark eyes bore into Katsuki. "With the sea you have a choice to sink or swim but staying on a doomed ship will only guarantee your death."

Katsuki's frown deepened, and chills crawled up his spine.

"What is that supposed to mean?" Katsuki whispered.

"It means you need to start thinking of *yourself*," Aizawa said very seriously. He let go of the paper and Katsuki stumbled back, not realizing how hard he had a grip on it. "Remember that, stay out of trouble and *please*, no more killing my goddamn men."

Katsuki stared at him, letting the meaning of the words settle into him. It was clear Aizawa was referring to his mother—but a defensive part of Katsuki didn't like it at all. He pressed his lips in a thin line as he thought about this and then decided to quickly end this strange relationship between them.

"Sure thing. See you, old man."

There was a flicker of sadness in Aizawa's eyes that he quickly snuffed out.

Katsuki glanced down at the wrinkled piece of paper and slowly started to make his way towards the door.

As he did this, he read the paper and it was pretty much proof of the assignment being completed. His mother's name was on it, while he was nowhere in sight. It was stamped 'Copy 1 of 3' and Katsuki could only assume that the other two copies were for The Company, and Imasuji Goto.

Katsuki reached the door and stopped as he looked at the large sum of money he had worked off in merely six months. He thought about the nice hotel room, the freedom he had this last month, and finally the control he felt for the first time in a year. His chest became restless when he considered going back to Osaka empty handed. He didn't know what was waiting there for him, the ground underneath his feet suddenly felt rocky.

It was only when Katsuki touched the cold doorknob, did he realize these last six months were the most stable he had ever been.

Because he had money. Because he had been in nice hotel rooms. Because he had food. Aizawa always made sure he was given proper attention. But ultimately, for once Katsuki didn't feel like he had to lean on his mother.

He thought about how sad his mother looked before he left. She was slipping. It would only be a matter of time before Katsuki would have to go back to writing endless papers and feeding himself and her.

Fuck it. Katsuki steeled his nerves and turned around. He marched straight up to Aizawa and slammed his hands flat on the surface of the wooden desk.

"Let me work here," Katsuki demanded solidly.

Aizawa blanched. "Have you lost your *mind*? Get out of my office—"

"—I can be good at this," Katsuki rushed. "Now hear me out—"

"—Absolutely *not*. Don't make me get my gun."

"I don't give a shit, you can shoot me if you want," Katsuki snapped. "Even if you shoot me I'm going to keep talking so you might as will just fucking listen."

Aizawa's face dropped in disbelief and his hand stopped moving under his desk. Probably was getting his shot gun ready for him, no doubt. The tired adult regarded Katsuki like he had grown a third eye in the last five seconds.

"I-I really fucking hate school but I'm smart," Katsuki blurted out. "I'm really positive I'm going to drop out soon anyways to go find a job the second I turn fifteen. I need money and I need *a lot* of it. My mom needs someone to take care of her and she can't do it herself. She—She's not able to. She tries, she does. But it's not enough. And before we left Osaka, I saw her slipping again and I have to find ways to take care of us before that happens."

Aizawa looked as though he was going to protest, but he couldn't find the proper words.

Katsuki continued, desperate as he pushed. "I have to take care of both of us, but no one will fucking hire me."

"There's good reasons for that. One fact being you're a *child*," Aizawa hissed. "Do you not comprehend that? My job is killing people or killing people when needed. This is no place for someone your age. You should be focused on other stuff—"

"—I should be," Katsuki agreed. He pleaded heavily with his eyes. "You're right, I should be. But I fucking *can't,* my life isn't set up that way. The only thing I can focus on is my next meal and making sure I have a place to sleep. I need money. I need a job—*this job*. I can be good at it. I'm a great learner and you know damn well I have no issues with death."

Aizawa looked like he pitied him.

Katsuki shrugged it off as he continued. "If you can change the course of the ship, wouldn't you? You don't always have to fucking jump overboard. Sometimes you just need to get

down and fucking dirty, roll up your sleeves and take the wheel. This is me taking the wheel."

"And what will you do if I tell you to fuck off?"

"I will go find someone else in the same business as you," Katsuki said coldly. "If it's not this company, it will be somewhere else. I highly doubt that this is the only place in all of Japan that has *hitmen* for hire."

At that, Aizawa seemed to give in.

He sighed deeply, looked up towards the ceiling and pinched the bridge of his nose.

"Kami fucking help me," Aizawa muttered. "A whole fucking migraine."

Katsuki chewed his lip as a long stretch of silence moved in the office space.

"Fine," Aizawa muttered. "Fucking *fine*. But you're not getting any red folder jobs any time soon. I'm going to need to train you and you'll have to live in range of headquarters a bit closer. I'm going to keep an *extremely* close eye on you. You're going to go to school and I'm going to require you to maintain a specific grade point average."

Katsuki yelled out in excitement and clapped his hands. He couldn't control the happy grin that spread across his face and Aizawa looked like he was a doomed man. The elder man placed his head in his palms as Katsuki pumped his fists.

"I promise you won't regret this, old man," Katsuki cheered, attempting to reassure him.

Aizawa looked more stressed out. "I'm already regretting this."

"Well—you won't regret it *more*. Nowhere to go but up from here, right?"

"Shut up." Aizawa groaned.

"I do have one question though," Katsuki paused. Aizawa's bloodshot eyes looked at him expectantly. "What's a red folder job?"

Aizawa sighed and shook his head. "You have a lot to learn."

☽ ☽ ☽

The next few years flew by with cash raining down and filling his pockets. Katsuki kept true to his word, and he stayed enrolled in school and kept his grades up. With income from both him and his mother, he didn't have to beg other students to do their work for them and could focus on his own grades.

But the best part about the double income, they could move to a large place. Aizawa helped them house shop around Yokohama, and it was like living out of one of the weirdly fancy catalogs. It almost felt too good to be true and Katsuki had to pinch himself to be sure.

They settled on a lavish condo that was well within range of The Company and he fucking loved it. So did his mother, who looked brand new walking about the fancy marble floored kitchen. Her smile was so bright, and her eyes were filled with a light he hadn't seen since his father passed. Originally, his mother rejected the idea, but after being shown how much money Katsuki would be getting, she quietly resigned.

"This would make you happy?" Mitsuki said as she stared at his contract.

"Yes, it would make me really happy. You too."

"But this is saying that you'll be tied to them for ten years. That's a really long time, Katsuki. Those are your good years."

"Ten years is nothing in the grand scheme of things," Katsuki said. He shrugged off her worry. "I'll be fucking twenty-five, money stacked up as high as Mount Fuji and we'll be living good, mom."

She eventually gave in.

To celebrate, she actually bought him a knife. It was sharp, stainless steel and it had his name engraved on it in gold on the hilt. Katsuki was surprised, stunned really. He had known she wouldn't exactly object, but this was something entirely different. She smiled at him as she handed it over, an edge of weariness in her eyes.

"I'm just happy you're happy," she said in a whisper and hugged him. "I'll be better from now on. I promise."

As the years progressed, Aizawa taught him how to dress properly. Katsuki found he actually had good taste despite being deprived of luxury goods for so long. He learned very quickly he liked black a lot. Black watch. Black Shoes. Black turtlenecks and pants. He grinned wide at the look of himself in his first tux with a black tie. Aizawa seemed happy too, pointing out how he had a good eye for these types of things.

The jobs he took from fourteen to seventeen were vanilla he would learn after he turned eighteen.

Aizawa strictly kept him off red folder assignments, which he learned very quickly were hits that ended in the death of the mark. Green was for safeguarding the mark and killing others if needed. Yellow was a wild card. Katsuki's assignments were filled with green, green, and more green. When he wasn't doing assignments, Aizawa was skillfully training him in combat, languages and computer coding. He told Katsuki every day The Company's motto so his empathy could be hammered down to the bottom of his sinking spirit.

"A mark is a mark," Aizawa said coldly every day after rigorous training. "Now say it."

"A mark is a mark," Katsuki repeated.

Those were words tattooed deeply on his brain. They rang loud every time he was on an assignment, ready to cut down anymore who came too close to his mark.

During this time, he was partnered up with a strange older man named Rin Hiryu. Hiryu had a mysterious numbered tattoo and aura leaking off of him and he was about as quiet as a ghost. The man moved in silence all the time and according to the office gossip, he had a dark past. Or at least, everyone thought he did based on the strange scars on his body and the numbered tattoo on his finger.

Katsuki learned Hiryu requested that he work purely on green assignments. The ghost like man never wanted to touch a yellow or red folder.

When Katsuki asked him why, he was given a simple answer:

“I want to spend the last part of my life protecting,” Hiryu said, entirely disengaged. His dark eyes were glazed over as he said this. It was clear he was trapped in his head. “It’s a personal goal of mine.”

“Half of our clients are drug lords,” Katsuki pointed out.

“Better to protect life than to take life greedily.”

Katsuki decided to leave it alone and just worked the assignment with Hiryu. Dude was weird and spoke like he was some wise poetic master, so it was whatever.

Despite Hiryu’s strange need to only want to work on green folders, Katsuki in contrast did not feel like this. In the entirely opposite sentiment, there was an ominous itch in Katsuki’s stomach when he wondered what it would be like to finally have that red folder for the first time. That darkness in his core gnawed at the mere prospect of it. It was eager and whispering in excitement for that fateful day that he might once again paint his hands in scarlet.

By the time Katsuki turned sixteen, he was worried about that blood thirsty nagging feeling in his core.

It was getting louder day by day and he wondered if he was truly a monster to *want* to attempt murder again. That wasn’t normal, right? He should be disgusted, feel like he was being forced but the fact was, he didn’t. He felt far from it, honestly. He was happy to be chosen for this and he was happy to be in training.

But when Katsuki was seventeen, a tiny sliver of information was revealed that flipped his world on its head. As he was walking to the kitchen area at The Company, he heard the office gossip whispering to someone. But this time it was about him.

“Why the hell is Aizawa letting that blond menace run around here?” Someone bitterly sneered. “I thought he had a policy against *corrupting* children or whatever he calls it.”

“You didn’t hear this from me but, look up Imasuji Goto.” the office gossip said with a smug tone. “That should tell you why.”

Katsuki had frozen in place.

Imasuji Goto. There was that fucking name again.

Eeriness scratched at the back of his skull, pestering him. He thought about his mother's strange reaction towards that name. He shouldn't give a shit about a man who wanted his mother's head decapitated and brought to him like he was some fucking emperor in the ancient days—

—but.

He couldn't help but be curious. He thought about what the office gossip said.

What was the connection between them and Imasuji Goto?

☽ ☽ ☽

Later that night, Katsuki was sent on a two weeklong assignment with Hiryu to some random small town. They packed their bags immediately and he told his mom. She hugged him goodbye and told him to be safe as if he wasn't the one who was about to inflict damage and enjoy it.

The assignment was simple: they were hired by some shop owner to protect against the neighborhood thugs. The gang had been bothering the shop owners, stealing products from them and intimidating them with guns and knives. Hiryu and Katsuki had to scare them off and wipe them out if absolutely needed.

The small-town citizens had pooled their money to try to solve the *vermin* issue.

On the second night of the assignment, Katsuki had been scrolling the web, looking up the gangster Imasuji Goto. It only took a couple minutes for Katsuki to discover the man was as foul as they came. He was involved with drugs, arson, battery, several assault charges, and he had various murder convictions under his belt. The most absurd one was suspected under suspicions of cannibalism and tied to human trafficking.

Katsuki's stomach turned with every file and news article about the man he read. He was currently out of prison due to his strange, lucid connections. Like many gangsters and terrifying humans who possessed power. The law couldn't contain real monsters, the true demons were able to evade and terrorize the world. Many of Imasuji Goto's crimes were so fucking *horrifying*. He gained the nickname 'Muscular' due to camera footage catching him ripping a man's arm clean off then staring straight into the lens.

Against his better judgment, Katsuki watched the clip.

But the carnage wasn't the most unsettling thing.

It was the man's fair skin and spiky blond hair. Even in the dark, static camera footage, it was clear. His sharp eyes, deep frown and angular features. The way his chin rounded out in the same way as Katsuki's and squared out at his jaw line. They had the same eye shape and same type of frown.

Everything in Katsuki's world slowed down like he had been transported to his worst nightmare that he never considered. The longer he looked at that blurry footage, the more

Katsuki realized he needed to get back home. He replayed it. Over and over, watching the bloody butchery and studying the enigmatic gangster.

After the fourth repeat of the footage, Katsuki decided he had to speak with his mother right now.

The job was finished in a week's time with Katsuki's new frantic mindset.

A piece of him was deeply shaken by what he had unearthed. He hoped that tiny intuition in the back of his mind was fucking lying to him because his father was his father. Right? Fucking right? His mother wouldn't keep that type of thing from him—his *father* wouldn't have kept that type of thing from him?

With shaky hands, Katsuki printed out the mugshot of Imasuji Goto. He folded it neatly and put it in his suit's pants pocket that night. He boarded the plane back to Yokohama with the vicious blood covered smile of Muscular imprinted on his mind.

The man smirked in the same way the darkest part of him did.

☽ ☽ ☽

When Katsuki came home, the stench of cigarettes and alcohol was stronger than he had ever smelled it before. The acrid aroma burned his nostrils harshly and made him nearly gag. His cheeks burned with disgust as he walked through the house, sniffing the subtle tinge of rotting fruit and a neglected garbage.

He picked up his foot as he stepped over pieces of thrown away clothes and random discarded pieces of plastic he couldn't identify. When he stepped into the living room, it was full of people smoking, gambling and chatting it up like some goddamn *party*.

Sitting in the center on the couch, was his mother. She was grinning wide with a hand full of poker cards and money stacked in bands in front of her. The seedy crowd surrounding her was cheering, and he watched. He fucking watched her offer up a large sum of cash and he watched her lose it all. But all she did was smile and laugh.

Katsuki immediately fucking lost his temper at the sight.

"Everyone get the fuck out," Katsuki demanded in a low voice.

His anger simmered under his skin as he glared at all the strange men and women sitting in the living room. They all gawked at him in surprise and his mother gasped. She sprung up from her seat on the couch and quickly straightened out her pencil skirt.

Mitsuki quickly rushed over to him, fixing her pearls as the people in the background watched them carefully.

"Katsuki, you're home early—"

"I said, everyone get the *fuck* out!" Katsuki yelled again, not giving her the time of day. He was pissed off beyond belief. His eyes stung with pure, unchecked rage.

When no one moved he whipped back his blazer to grab the loaded gun on his hip holster. He cocked it threateningly and it earned a sharp gasp from several people in the room when he pointed it at the first person he saw.

This time everyone scattered like ants. Cards were tossed carelessly like confetti to the ground, people were grabbing colorful chips and shoving wads of cash into their pockets. Some people were elbowing each other unkindly, trying to get to the exit quickly. The mass of gamblers scattered out of the apartment and the door slammed behind them.

The silence cut raw.

Katsuki leered at the alcohol, needles, and cards that were sloppily around the apartment. The apartment *he* was fucking paying for. This was supposed to be their new home, a nice place for them and yet—once again—his mother let in the very thing that was the cause of the many times they were in trouble. Over and over and fucking over again.

"Mom, what the *fuck* is this?" Katsuki snapped immediately. "I thought you said you were going to be better?! You said no more fucking gambling—is this what you do when I'm away?! *Hah*!? What is wrong with you!?"

"Katsuki, it wasn't a real game of poker, it was a fake one," Mitsuki lied poorly.

"I'm not goddamn stupid," Katsuki groaned. He picked up one of the half-drunk bottles of vodka and angrily stormed over to the sink to pour it out. He watched the liquid fall down the drain and his chest felt like it was going to crack under pressure. This was too much. This was all too fucking much.

"This—this has gone on far too long," Katsuki said. "You have to stop. You can't keep doing this. I thought you were going to be better than this, Mom."

"I *am* better, Katsuki," Mitsuki said. She sounded hurt. "Those needles aren't mine and I didn't touch the liquor. I was just playing a little game of clean poker. I am better, *really*."

"No, you're fucking not!" Katsuki screamed. He gestured wildly to the torn-up apartment. "Look at this place! This is *disgusting*!"

Mitsuki frowned. "So what? You think I am a bad mother?"

Katsuki groaned viciously and angrily tossed down the glass bottle in the sink. It shattered harshly, jagged broken pieces of glass flew everywhere, adding to the mess. His mother didn't flinch, used to his outbursts by now.

"You know *damn well* that's not what I fucking meant—"

"—No, it's okay, Katsuki," Mitsuki spat back sarcastically. She dug in the words, and they got under his skin even though he tried not to let them. "You can fucking *say it*. I bet you've been thinking that forever. I'm probably the worst goddamn mother in the world to you!"

"Now you're being fucking dramatic—"

“—It’s not dramatic, I can see it in your eyes!” Mitsuki yelled, clutching her shirt. “I-It fucking hurts to see you look at me the way you do! I can *see* how disappointed you are, and I realized that there hasn’t been a moment since Tokyo where you haven’t looked at me like you were disappointed.”

Her face crumpled like paper as she looked down to the marble floor.

“But there’s a lot about me you don’t know, Katsuki. I’m sorry that my life fell apart the way it did. I truly am, I never intended for it to…and I wish my best could be better for you but it’s not. But I am giving my best, is that not worth something?”

Katsuki pursed his lips as he looked away from her.

He knew what this game was. She was trying to make him pity her and it was fucking working. It *always* fucking worked, and he hated how goddamn heavy his heart suddenly felt.

“I just want you to know that I have always had your best intentions in mind, Katsuki. There’s not a decision in my life that doesn’t revolve around what would be best for you.”

At that, Katsuki scoffed sarcastically. “*Really*? Leaving me fucking homeless in the streets in the middle of fucking winter was the best decision for me?”

“They were trying to take you from me, Katsuki,” Mitsuki said harshly. “I have always gone the extra mile to make sure you stay with me. Would you rather I let you be shipped off to some orphanage and put in the system? Do you know how goddamn low the adoption rate for kids over five is?”

Katsuki then thought about the photograph burning in his pocket.

“What about that man?” Katsuki said a question that had been looming on his mind like a dark cloud. “Imasuji Goto.”

At the name drop, his mother flinched like she had been slapped. Her sharp eyes became dangerous knives that carved into him, and she bared her teeth like a vicious animal.

“Don’t you dare fucking mention that name.”

“And why the hell not?” Katsuki pushed. His emotions were tipping on the edge and was unable to catch them as he toppled straight over the edge. “You know that whole fucking thing was strange. The money you owed him, the fucking *timing*. But you know what was more strange? Someone who works with Aizawa said that I *looked* like him.”

“Katsuki. You don’t want to go down this path,” his mother warned dangerously.

“Why not?” Katsuki pressed on cruelly. His heart hammered until it was pulsing in his throat. “Why the hell shouldn’t I go down it? What is at the end of it?”

Silence bubbled as Mitsuki gripped the edge of the garnet countertop.

“Y’know, I dug around and I found a picture of him,” Katsuki confessed. He flared his nose and dug into his suit pockets. He angrily tossed the blurry photograph of the gangster on the tabletop towards his mother. She averted her eyes without a moment’s hesitation. “Fucking tell me. Why. do. I. Look. Like *him*?”

Mitsuki’s face fell slightly but she expertly steeled her serious expression. She flipped the photo face down.

“There’s plenty of blond men in fucking Japan. Hell, I’m blonde. You look like *me*.”

“Mom. This goes beyond hair color. I physically *resemble* him—”

“—No. You’re not doing this to me. Masaru is your damn father,” Mitsuki shut him down. She gave him the most vicious stare he ever saw her muster, defensive and on edge. “You’re not going to shit all over your father’s memory with this *bullshit* because you stuck your nose in something you know damn well you shouldn’t have.”

She angrily grabbed the photo and ripped it to shreds with all her rage.

Out of spite, she threw the pieces up in the air and Katsuki glared at her harshly as the tiny pieces fell all around him. Her reaction was enough of an answer. He didn’t need to ask any further questions as the paper pieces of the photograph landed in his hair.

“Believe it or not Katsuki, I have made very big decisions to make sure you were *safe*,” Mitsuki hissed, stepping into his space. “I’ve seen parents give up their kids to some evil fucking people. Hell, I was even *asked* to when it was apparent I was struggling. I’ve seen people treat kids like fucking *merchandise*—I just wanted to make sure you always stayed with *me*.”

Katsuki was about to ask her what the fuck did that even mean, but he was cut off as she continued on her rant.

“Erasing that evil man was the very first decision I made to ensure *you* had a good future.” She swallowed and Katsuki could feel the truth prickling in the air. “Your father is *Masaru* and he always has been and always *will* be. I did what I had to do to make sure you had a good example because I know damn well it wasn’t ever going to be me. Trust me—I *know* I’m not a good example.”

Katsuki felt his spirit wallow hearing this.

He knew what the answer was. He did. But hearing his mother say it made it all more real.

“Then Masaru died,” Mitsuki whispered, eyes glossing over. “He loved us just as much as we loved him. Masaru was *supposed* to be your role model, Katsuki. I made *sure* of that. I didn’t owe that bastard money; I *stole* it so I could *get away* from him when I found out I was pregnant. You were supposed to be like Masaru, good and pure. Not like me. The last thing I wanted you to be was like me or that goddamn gangster.”

Her tears spilled down her face and Katsuki felt his already broken heart shatter further.

“Mom. Stop—”

“—I’m sorry.” Mitsuki whispered. Her voice cracked and all her composure went out of the window. “I’m really sorry, Katsuki. I-I tried to give you the best father and the best role model because there are *so* many monsters in the world. I’m one of them and so is Imasuji. You deserved to have an angel as your father, because I wanted you to be an angel too. S-So please. Leave this buried where it’s at. There’s so much about this world that you don’t understand.”

Katsuki stared around at the disaster in their condo. His heart squeezed until he couldn’t breathe as he tried to absorb this.

Dirty clothes. Poker cards. Rotten fruit and dirty dishes.

Now this.

This whole time his father was—

Katsuki swallowed. This wasn’t what his new home was supposed to be. It was supposed to be fucking warm, full of laughter and nothing but good goddamn times. He did all the grimy shit at work so he could come back to see his mother smile and live his goddamn life normally. *This* wasn’t what he had envisioned at all. He started wondering if his home would ever actually be with his mother.

He stared at the tiny pieces of the photograph all around, scattering the truth of his life. It suddenly all made a clear, scary amount of sense. He didn’t know how to feel as his chest expanded with searing emotions that were far too bitter for him to swallow.

It was then he realized he was finally taller than his mother.

He towered over her now, no longer looking up to her, but looked down at the brittle mess she was. She always was so fragile, strung together by nothing but doing her best and unfulfilled promises. She was smaller than he remembered, always inflated by the illusion of childhood heroes and love. Now he could see her for what she was, but he didn’t know if he liked it.

He didn’t know what her past life was—and Katsuki didn’t *want* to know.

“I—I need space,” Katsuki whispered, finally solidifying his decision. He could hear Aizawa’s advice from when he was fourteen burned into his head: *Put yourself first.*

Mitsuki wiped her tears and waved her hand, shrugging it off like she always did. This was a cycle. Katsuki could see it now.

“Go take a walk like you always do, Katsuki. You’ll be fine—”

“No,” Katsuki cut off. He shook his head, and his body was juddering. Were the tremors from exhaustion or rage? He couldn’t exactly identify. “Not that type of space. I don’t think I can keep living with you.”

Mitsuki froze.

The leaky faucet creaked between them. Drip by drip it creeped and counted the endless passing seconds. With every moment that lacked words, Katsuki found his skin crawling. He needed to get out. He needed room to fucking breathe, and his mother was stealing all his air.

“I’ll still come to visit but I can’t keep doing this. I need my own space.”

She turned her gaze away from him sadly and nodded her head. “Okay. I get it.”

“I’m going to take a walk. Don’t bother waiting up for me,” Katsuki muttered under his breath, still averting his gaze.

Neither mother nor son could look at each other.

After the painful reveal, Katsuki took a slow walk around the block. He strolled in the cold night with nothing but a leather jacket as his eyes burned with tears. The tears were banging against his eyes, begging to be let out and allow himself to feel. But he just fucking shoved it down. He shoved it down to the deepest, darkest part of him and that depraved side of him consumed it whole.

It smiled at him and suddenly he hated what he was. He wanted to scratch at his skin, dig his nails into his flesh and veins and claw out the evil that was lurking all around inside of him.

Katsuki had always wondered what kind of monster he was. He pondered if he was a product of his environment or truly born violent with no real hope. He wondered this question night and day.

Why had he not felt remorse killing that man so long ago?

Why had he *wanted* to kill again?

Why did he beg Aizawa for a job that entailed killing people?

He thought maybe he was a forged monster—a necessary evil given his shitty life circumstance. But really maybe his destiny was never his. He was the product of a monster and a disaster. Maybe it was in his blood to be the vicious, violent person he was. Even if he was given another set of cards for life, would he have turned out to be the same scarlet painted person?

Did he fool himself into thinking he have ever been fucking *normal*?

As Katsuki was walking down the jagged sidewalk, his work phone rang.

The ringtone he set for Aizawa chimed on and he took in a deep breath. He pushed down all those pondering thoughts and decided to accept he wasn’t normal now that he knew his true bloodline. He answered the phone with a tired, low voice.

“What do you need, old man?”

“I got a new assignment for you,” Aizawa said coolly. “Have you ever been to Vienna?”

Chapter End Notes

Let me know your thoughts! Sorry about any spelling mistake you found. I was really beat from work and Luna is sick :< I hope you still enjoyed this! Let me know your thoughts below.

Next chapter is Interlude III, and it's 17-25 year old Katsuki :) Specifically, its gonna be the fun stuff of the 8 years of run-ins with Izuku. I originally wanted all of the Katsuki background one chapter but there's a lot to unpack here lol so it'll be in doses!

Thanks so much for reading! 💜

Chapter 12: Interlude III

Chapter Summary

Katsuki earns the title of The Scarlet Eyed Killer

Chapter Notes

Hello everyone!! I hope you had a wonderful day!

First up, big thank you to Luna for betaing! She says thank you all for the get well wishes and everything ^^ she is feeling much better now and loves you all.

Secondly, I hope you enjoy this chapter! Originally, this was going to be a monster chapter of like 30k lol but i decided to cut it in two and leave it at where I think is a good resting spot so let all the events digest well! I'm really excited to be progressing through these flashback chapters as we unravel Katsuki's complexity. Thank you all so much for sticking around 200k+ words into this story. It means alot!

Now that's over, buckle up! :)

Warnings: Homocide, violent sexual tension

See the end of the chapter for more notes



By Nez on Twitter

Chapter 12 — Interlude III

.

.

.

Deku. Deku, Deku, Deku, fucking *Deku*.

That was the name Katsuki had decided on for that green haired bastard. He repeated this name obsessively as the two lead bullets in his flesh tore him apart.

That night in Vienna was one of the worst instances of Katsuki's life. He had felt so foolish laying on that cold rooftop, but above all he felt helpless. He hadn't felt this out of control since he was fourteen as he struggled on the ground. His limbs were running cold, all the

warmth in his body left out along with the blood that he needed. He defenselessly groaned, struggling to stay conscious.

He witnessed the life seep out of Hiryu's brown eyes. The saturated, cinnamon color desaturated to a stale darkness that was burned into Katsuki's mind. Alongside that memory, his hatred for the man who was Hiryu's murderer grew exponentially out of control. Katsuki gritted his teeth as he crawled on the dirty concrete away from the blood that was inching closer to him.

He pushed past the agonizing pain pulsing in his muscles to dig into his pocket. He dialed the emergency number for the third member of their Vienna mission. The phone rang three times, and slowly Katsuki's vision started to vignette black with the more blood he lost.

"Hello? Bakugou?" The other hitman said on the opposite line. "What's up? Did you guys secure the roof?"

Katsuki answered in his head, "*Help*—" but no word was actually formed by his tongue. His mouth felt numb and heavy. He made a muffled cry for help.

"Bakugou, what's wrong? What's going on?"

But Katsuki couldn't answer.

Instead, he dropped the phone when his body went limp from the loss of blood. As he closed his eyes, all he could see was the vision of Rin's dead body and the swirling color of green that had turned his life upside down.

When he looked back on it, Katsuki would be bitter to admit that the mysterious assailant did him a favor.

☽ ☽ ☽

Eventually Katsuki woke up, the beeping of hospital monitors blared through him. He blinked his eyes open slowly and his mind was foggy. The weight of his eye lids were something he was unfamiliar with, as he tried to gain a bearing on what the fuck was going on.

"Ah, you're finally awake. You sure did take your time coming back to the land of the living."

Katsuki didn't need to be fully conscious to know that tired ass voice was Aizawa's.

The young hitman groaned as he rolled his neck to the side.

Katsuki set his heavy eyes on Aizawa who was reading the newspaper casually. When he glanced at the big, bold headline he saw it was in German, as was all the other text. He concluded he was still in Vienna, at least.

Then unexpectedly, the ghostly memory of Rin Hiryu's lifeless eyes boring into him struck Katsuki's nerves.

Katsuki bolted up, heart pounding.

“*Hiryu*. He’s—”

“—Dead. Yes.” Aizawa didn’t flinch. He thumbed to the next page of the newspaper and Katsuki didn’t realize the old man could read German. “Several gunshots. Same for you, only you’re alive.” Aizawa lowered down the flimsy paper to finally show his exhausted face. “Should we talk about this now or do you want to wait until we get back to Japan?”

“We—We can talk about it now,” Katsuki whispered.

His vision swarmed a bit, lightheaded.

Aizawa apparently saw him sway because he stood up quickly. His supervisor walked over and poured him a cup of water from a glass pitcher by his bedside. He handed it to Katsuki in silence and waited patiently for him to gulp it down. There was a clear ticking in the background, reminding Katsuki of time as he did this.

When he put the cup down, his hand was shaking.

“Are you okay now?” Aizawa asked, a little bit of concern in his voice. Katsuki nodded and felt his throat. “Good. Now, I need you to tell me everything—I mean *everything*. Losing a man on an assignment is an extremely serious matter.”

“There was some fucking assassin,” Katsuki rasped out. He now suddenly was aware of the dull pain creeping up his arms from the gunshot wounds. “He had stupid ass green hair and green eyes. He posed as a waiter inside of the restaurant we were in. He took my order. Not Hiryu’s though, which I guess now that I say this out loud, was suspicious. Hiryu didn’t see him.”

Aizawa frowned deeper than he had ever seen. “He got that close to you?”

“Yes,” Katsuki said, slightly ashamed. “He didn’t look like a threat, really. I honestly couldn’t tell. He looked like a normal teenager. Then when Hiryu and I went to the roof to cover the exit of the diplomat—that guy just fucking snuck up on us. He killed Hiryu and shot me and left me there to bleed out.”

“Describe him.”

“I just told you he had green hair and eyes.”

“I need more than his hair color and eyes, Bakugou,” Aizawa said tiredly.

“He, uh.” Katsuki paused, struggling to find the right words in his foggy brain.

He hated how when he remembered that killer all he could see was that sweet looking doll face. He still perfectly remembered the cute dimples, stunning eyes, and how the silk shirt complemented him so fucking well. Katsuki wished his damn brain would hurry up and twist the memory to something darker, something more deserving of a cold-blooded killer—but it didn’t.

Instead, the freckled man stayed painted in the soft tint of the first impression that he gave.

“He had freckles,” Katsuki settled for, feeling disgusted with himself. “A lot of goddamn stupid freckles, curly hair, lean frame. Short. He looked about my age, maybe younger—I don’t fucking *know*.”

He was feeling defensive. His dumb heart was tugging and weighing down like there was an anchor hooked into it. Then that chilling detached stare from those same sweet green eyes clouded his mind. He was so cold. He didn’t even blink. Abruptly, Katsuki remembered the few words exchanged.

“*Wait*. He said something in Korean to Hiryu before he shot him. Then told me Hiryu was his mark before he left me to bleed to death.”

“His *mark*? So Hiryu had a hit on him.” Aizawa scratched his chin. “What did he say to Hiryu?”

“I don’t know, I can’t speak Korean,” Katsuki grumbled.

“Just give me your best impression of what he said phonetically,” Aizawa encouraged. “Hiryu spoke twelve languages and I know some Korean. Maybe what was said might give us a clue of if this was a personal issue or if it’s a company issue. If it’s something to do with The Company, I need to be more worried about it.”

Katsuki repeated what the stranger had said in choppy, off pitch tones.

Aizawa winced a bit and struggled to even understand what he said. Katsuki tried his best to make his parched tongue twist until the unfamiliar language seemed to click in Aizawa’s head.

“*Hyung*?” Aizawa repeated, sounding baffled. “He called him his *brother*?”

“Is that what that means?” Katsuki muttered.

“Sort of. It can mean older brother or it can mean older males you are close to. I’m unsure what the first half means. So either that was his brother or someone he knew very closely.”

“I didn’t realize Hiryu *had* fucking family,” Katsuki muttered. Now he felt bitter. “He always said he didn’t have any family whenever I asked him.”

Aizawa’s lips pressed together in thin lines, the bags underneath his eyes somehow appearing darker. He pulled up a chair by the bedside and he took in a deep inhale, shoulders sagging.

“I run background checks on everyone I hire but Hiryu was virtually invisible,” Aizawa confessed. “I almost didn’t let him contract with us because of this, but he seemed so… anxious. There was something broken inside of him when he came to me. He was desperate for a job, and he said he needed the help to make him and his girlfriend invisible.”

“And you let him?” Katsuki asked, surprised.

“I have a weak spot for stray mutts with sob stories,” Aizawa said pointedly. “I’m sure he gave me a fake last name—but even when I cross ran all the possible leads he had no legal siblings or family on record. Further unfortunate news, Hiryu’s girlfriend was found dead in their apartment when I sent Miruko over to tell her about Hiryu. It seems like this was a job to snuff them both out. I think this is a fair lesson in the fact that the past doesn’t always stay dead, no matter how far you run from it.”

There was nothing else Katsuki could say.

He tried to search himself for other feelings, but inside of him only two emotions were present. First, the coiling hatred for the killer and lastly sympathy for Hiryu and his lover. He hoped that maybe that assassin was simply twisted in the head to call Hiryu his older brother. What type of person would kill their *sibling* in cold blood like that?

The bastard went so far to track him down in an entirely different *country*.

As Katsuki laid stiffly in the bed, all he could really see were flashes of Hiryu’s face. He recalled the way the man would smile at him like a wise mentor and always speak in riddles. Then he realized all those small instances were now gone. Forever.

“I’m sorry you had to see Hiryu die so brutally, Bakugou,” Aizawa quietly said. Sympathy translated through Aizawa’s brown eyes, and it made Katsuki unbearably uncomfortable. “That’s not an easy thing to witness. Are you alright?”

Katsuki deflected. “I’ve seen people die before. In case you forgot, my father is dead.”

“Yes, I know. But you’ve never seen someone you knew personally get *murdered*,” Aizawa pointed out. “That’s very different than watching a stranger get murdered. Or seeing your father die of sickness gradually at a young age. So, I repeat, are you alright?”

A pause of silence.

The memory of Hiryu dying seeped vividly into Katsuki’s mind like a bloodstain spreading across fresh linen.

“…Yeah,” Katsuki forced himself to say. “I’ll be fine.”

Both Aizawa and Katsuki knew this wasn’t the full truth.

Sure, he would eventually be okay but right now he wasn’t. He felt stuck, like his feet were caught in a slew of quicksand dragging him down. Katsuki was unsure how to process the loss of an associate. Should he cry? Curse? Hunt down the man who did it and kill him to avenge Hiryu? He really didn’t fucking *know*. Katsuki tried to recall how he processed his own father’s death—then he realized he hadn’t.

He had never been given the moment to truly let such a thing settle in.

The dark, hungry part of him had been birthed instead. It consumed and consumed until he no longer felt the hurt of grief.

“Okay,” Aizawa said. He awkwardly rocked on his feet, not good at the whole comforting thing. The elder hitman patted Katsuki’s shoulder which earned him a disdained frown. “Er. Well, your mother is here.”

Katsuki whipped his head hard enough to double his neck pain.

“*Hah*? What the hell is she doing here?”

“You’ve been out for three days,” Aizawa clarified. Katsuki’s eyebrows shot up. “I notified her when they found your body on the rooftop and she demanded to come see you. She seemed rather distressed. She hadn’t left your side until this morning when I told her she should go out for fresh air. She should be coming back soon.”

“I don’t fucking want her here,” Katsuki snapped. “Tell her to get back on that damn plane and I’ll see her when I go get my things to move out.”

Aizawa grew quiet, clearly stunned by this. “What do you mean by that?”

“It *means* I don’t want to see her.”

The elder hitman opened and closed his mouth, as if wanting to say more. He cleared his throat and then frowned deeply. “Kid. I’m not sure what happened between you two, but I talked to her about some things that might help you both out—”

As if on cue, his mother waltzed in with a bouquet of flowers.

He frowned at the tears in her eyes and how fancy she was dressed. She had on her signature soft lavender cardigan, black pencil skirt and white blouse. Her neck was decorated in those shiny white pearls she never let go of and the wedding ring on her widowed hand was shined perfectly new.

“Ah! Katsuki, you’re awake,” she said very happily. “Fuck. I’m so glad. I was worried.”

She rushed over, placed the flowers on his lap and gave him a tight hug. She squeezed him warmly, but Katsuki let his arms hang limply at his side, not returning the gesture. Aizawa raised a brow.

Katsuki’s chest reverberated with resentment.

He recalled the last time he spoke to his mother before boarding the flight to Vienna. He thought about his dad—er, *dads*? Katsuki furrowed his brow, still digesting the information that was dropped he had ignored very bluntly.

“I’m so glad you’re okay,” Mitsuki whispered. She withdrew back, ignoring how Katsuki didn’t seem too ecstatic to see her.

Katsuki’s eyes evaded hers and landed blankly on the television. He didn’t let any emotion show in his face. “You didn’t have to come all the way out here.”

“Sure I did, brat,” Mitsuki teased as if they were fucking fine. “You’re my only kid. What kind of mother would I be to get the call that my son was nearly killed then *not* come out to the hospital?”

Katsuki bit his tongue. He decided against telling her it would fit her track record.

“Well, I’m okay,” Katsuki mumbled under his breath. “I’m always okay.”

“I’m going to go talk to some of the other agents to gather more details about Hiryu’s mysterious bother slash killer,” Aizawa quickly announced when the tension prickled his skin. “I’ll see you guys a little later.”

Mother and son waved goodbye to him as he stood up and exited the room swiftly. Katsuki was both relieved and irritated to be left alone with his mother. He was glad Aizawa didn’t have to see the embarrassment of their strained interaction. However, Katsuki was unhappy he had to face her now.

She walked around the bedside, holding her designer leather bag on her shoulder and sat where Aizawa was just at. Her eyes were soft and genuinely caring as she reached to hold his hand.

Katsuki shifted out of her touch.

Hurt danced across Mitsuki’s face. She retracted her hand and toyed with her fingers in her lap.

“I knew this job would be dangerous for you, Katsuki,” Mitsuki muttered. “But today it sunk in that you have been risking your life to do things like pay my rent. Pay my electric bill. Pay for things I should be paying for you. You’re only seventeen and you’ve already had one brush with death.”

Katsuki clicked his tongue. “Two.”

“Two?” Mitsuki questioned. She seemed genuinely confused.

“I nearly had hypothermia in Tokyo. When you left me there in the winter by myself without proper clothes.”

He knew he was being cruel to remind her of that. She actively avoided discussing it, but Katsuki felt fed up. He was goddamn *sick* of this dizzying circle they were always trapped in. The ticking clock strummed on as his mother didn’t utter another word and Katsuki stared at the wall.

“I’m going to get better. For real this time,” Mitsuki whispered, barely audible.

Katsuki exhaled deeply and shook his head. “You don’t have to keep making promises you can’t keep. It’s starting to get really fucking annoying.”

“No, I mean it this time. No more gambling. Getting that call felt like when I got the call for Masaru.” She paused and looked down at her wedding ring. “Seeing you unconscious in this

hospital bed just like him made me realize that I was close to losing you too. If I don't get better then I'm going to lose time with you. Even though it's late. Maybe you could even quit this job and get out of that contract."

"I signed a binding contract, I can't quit," Katsuki said curtly. "Besides, I would rather keep working and risk my life this way than the other way. At least I'm in control of how I am in danger."

He knew he was cruel for that one too. He should stop pushing her failures directly in her face, but he wanted her to grasp all the damage she inflicted.

Mitsuki sucked on her teeth as if tasting her words before speaking. "Well. I will still try to be better. I promise. I'm going to go get help as soon as we get back to Japan."

He nodded, tired. He was ready to move on from this pointless shit.

He noticed she hadn't inquired how he was doing like Aizawa had. He thought about the strangled, helpless sound Hiryu had made before the bullet sank into his skull.

His mother hugged him, then began talking about how she walked around Vienna the last few days. Mitsuki discussed how she had never been out of the country and how beautiful the city was. As she did this, Katsuki quietly relived the moment he witnessed his friend die in his head.

He looked down at the flowers she had laid on the bed and noticed they were her favorite. Not his.

Pink carnations.

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki didn't take his mother's promise of getting better seriously.

He always wanted to believe her, like a naive child. He always thought the older someone was the wiser they should be. But as he looked at his mother, he didn't believe that anymore. He was unsure if he really ever could because all he saw was a fragile, struggling human who *happened* to give birth to him.

Because of this, when they got back to Japan, Katsuki promptly moved out.

His mother tried to stop him, thinking they would move past the spat they had. But Katsuki remained unmoving like a mountain in his decision. The truth about his biological father solidified that he was sick of the life he was living and needed space to figure out things on his own.

The apartment he bought was luxe and directly in downtown Yokohama. It was everything he always imagined himself living in: expensive wooden floors, high ceilings. Big ass bedrooms and a fridge stacked to the brim with his favorite foods. All the appliances inside were made of shiny, metallic crap he could barely pronounce. He even had a master bedroom along with

an at home ‘office’ space that was really just his room for sorting through his files. It made him feel more important than he was.

But the atmosphere of the apartment was wrong. Every time he walked in discomfort tugged at his bones. The whole space was hollow, and the prickling sense of superficialities stung against his skin.

“What is missing?” Katsuki had grumbled to himself.

He glared at the expensive abstract green and orange art he placed on the wall. Fancy shit like this was supposed to make him feel good. Right? What the hell was the point of all this if he still felt like he was homeless?

He thought back to how warm the house had been with his father. Masaru’s laughter would be like wind chimes and the three of them always hung out. They used to spend so much time together and Katsuki missed that type of attention. Even though he was no longer that kid, he was still searching for a place that felt similar.

Then he thought about the nook in Tokyo.

The warmth of the boy from the city had comforted him so much he hadn’t minded living in an abandoned building for nearly a year. Then he realized it was because it felt like a home. That shotty little shit hole made him feel welcomed, and excited.

He failed to put his finger on it, but what was the anatomy of a home? What made its spine and forged its bones?

Katsuki couldn’t figure it out as he sat in this carcass of an apartment that felt painfully empty.

☽ ☽ ☽

As the months went on without him and his mother living together, something clicked in Mitsuki. Surprisingly, for the first time in Katsuki’s life his mother actually tried to get better in a different manner.

Usually when she made her empty promises, she would straighten out her wardrobe and clean the apartment. She would hide all the liquor at the top of the cabinets as though that would really keep her from it. She would throw out her poker cards and put the chips in a shoe box underneath her bed. These were all half efforts to really get better. Performative even. Katsuki could tell she was keeping her vices within reach if she ever wanted them again.

But this time was different. Instead of making a lackluster attempt, she went to the doctor.

“I had talked to someone,” his mother said on the day she came back from seeing the physician. “He—I mean *they* suggested that I should go talk to a doctor. I’m going to start seeing a therapist and I’m going to start on some medication.”

“What kind of medication?” Katsuki had asked. “Anti-depressant or something?”

His mother pursed her lips. “Nothing you have to concern yourself with. Alright?”

Katsuki scoffed. What a stupid thing to say. “I always have to concern myself with you in case something goes wrong. Just tell me.”

“No. It’s private,” Mitsuki pushed back. “Only thing you have to know is that I’m taking steps to be more functional. That’s all a *kid* like you should be concerning yourself with.”

A kid. Katsuki glowered. He was immediately rubbed wrong because that sounded straight out of Aizawa’s damn mouth.

“I pick up a *gun* every day to pay *your* bills,” Katsuki jeered. “Any notion of being a kid was buried a long time ago when I buried that body for you, so just tell me. Why the hell are you being so defensive?”

That was apparently the wrong thing to say. His mother grimaced so deeply, the muscles on her face looked like they were twitching.

“If I say it’s none of your concern, it’s none of your *goddamn* concern.”

“But—”

“—No!” She nearly screamed. Tears clung to the edge of her eyes now, ready to spill down as she yelled at him. “Leave it alone and worry about your damn self, Katsuki!”

“Oh. That’s fucking *rich*,” Katsuki barked maliciously. “If I had to only worry about myself I wouldn’t have signed that goddamn contract with Aizawa. Stop acting like you’re on some weird fucking high horse suddenly unless you’re not really taking medicine. You’re probably just fucking lying again, aren’t you?”

His mother snapped on him after that.

He wanted to tell her to calm down and simply tell him what medication, but she chewed him out. When he pressed on it further, she raised her voice to an ear shattering tone, tantrum in full swing. Out of rage, he raised his voice back until they were like clashing storms. Without fail, they got into a big blow out and this time when Katsuki waltzed out the apartment, he didn’t look back. He slammed the door hard enough to shake the walls and he could hear her crying from inside.

His mother was angry at someone.

Whether that someone was herself or him he wasn’t sure. But he felt an irreversible shift between them.

He was bitter about being shielded from whatever she was doing—or taking. He was partly concerned it wasn’t actually medication, but Katsuki had to remind himself not to give a shit if she got better or not. She wasn’t going to. Years of empty promises had left nothing but sore spots littered all over his heart.

When he went to bed that night, part of his sympathy for her died.

He sent her the money for her bills every month and they barely spoke afterwards.

☽ ☽ ☽

In the months following, silence was the only tie between mother and son.

Aizawa noticed this, especially when Katsuki's high school graduation rolled around, and his mother had simply given him a halfway hug. No presents. No 'I'm proud of you'. Nothing but a cheap smile and a small clap. The elder hitman had asked Katsuki what happened, but the young blond deflected. He mumbled under his breath and said it was nothing.

Aizawa obviously didn't believe him. But Katsuki couldn't bear to explain to the same man who told him to jump ship, that he wish he fucking had.

At the dinner that consisted of Aizawa, his mother and Miruko, the three adults chatted. Katsuki could tell his mother was different during these sparse moments of interaction. She seemed more present. His mother didn't seem intimidated like she usually did. Normally she would attempt to play up her life to cover her insecurities.

She actually seemed better, and it soured Katsuki.

Maybe the distance was good. Maybe they were better off and this whole time they were each other's destructive tendencies.

"I haven't gambled in months," she told him privately once Miruko and Aizawa left the fancy restaurant. She smiled at him softly. "I, uh, have been going to therapy. I also started going to a pottery class."

"That's good," Katsuki had replied. He gave her a strained, cautious smile. "Glad you're happy."

"What universities were you thinking of?" She asked, trying to push along the small talk.

"I wasn't planning on going to university. I don't really see the point since I make so much money per assignment."

Mitsuki frowned. "But what about after you finish with this job, what will you do?"

The idea of musical composition popped into Katsuki's mind. But he wasn't sure if he felt comfortable enough to tell her about that side of him ever again.

"I'll figure it out."

His icy demeanor chilled the air. He felt guilty to an extent, but he didn't feel like he trusted her anymore. He was waiting to see if she slipped once again and then finally he can be confirmed in his beliefs about her. She was in an unnerving vicious cycle, and she was going to drag Katsuki down with her if he stuck too closely.

She smiled sadly at him and paid for the meal.

They parted ways and didn't speak much again for several months.

☽ ☽ ☽

When Katsuki turned eighteen she sent him a basket of pink carnations and inside was a bunch of random stuff. All Might themed shit he had forgotten about. The basket was stuffed to the brim with the latest comics and it felt like a knife to the heart looking at these things now.

Unwillingly, the comics reminded him of Tokyo. More so, they reminded him of the kind boy who had helped him out that he left behind.

As he stared at these comics Katsuki frowned.

His memory was hazier as he tried to reach back to that year after a decade now. He could recall the distant sound of laughter, but the face of the boy was blurry now.

When did that happen?

He didn't even realize he had forgotten what he looked like. Time had slipped past him so much he could barely touch it and it felt like a distant daydream. As he searched his mind, he found it was now a tangled-up maze. Lurking in every corner was a dead body, or the dark side of him with the gruesome smile. He even saw his father and Hiryu laying there, stacked on top of each other. Their eyes were lifeless and dull.

Then finally he saw Imasuji Goto covered in blood. The vicious vision of the gangster chuckled in his mind.

"The apple never falls too far from the tree," he heard Imasuji Goto's static like voice speak to him in his mind. "Like father, like son. Right?"

Katsuki decided to stop reaching for his memory when that visual graced him. He put the comics down and shoved them underneath his bed.

☽ ☽ ☽

When he returned to The Company on his eighteenth birthday, everything changed.

"Welcome to the real show, kid." Aizawa said as he handed him a neat leather briefcase and ID card.

It had a green lanyard and his photo ID on it. Katsuki blinked at how official it looked. Damn. Had he really been playing the low part of the field this whole time? Katsuki pondered this as Aizawa led them to an entirely different part of the shiny building.

There were more doors and secret codes used. Hell, even Aizawa's eyeball and thumbprint were scanned. When they reached the new lobby, it was much more sterile. Instead of black colored walls it was a glaring, bright white color scheme and far quieter.

“This is Sector H. The part of The Company that deals with high profile requests, hence the H,” Aizawa said. “I run part of this along with half of Sector A, which is where we take more of the questionable requests. This part of the company is saved for a clientele that’s far more elite than specific standards. They tend to come with a stickier legal team.”

“Damn,” Katsuki said. He was fucking impressed. “And I’m part of Sector H now?”

“Yup. Under my supervision and recommendation. I’m putting you on M-Unit.”

Aizawa jutted his head towards a very large conference room made of glass with white table and chairs. Inside were several people waiting. Katsuki squinted his eyes and noticed there were four figures sitting inside chatting casually and goofing around. Right before they opened the clear door to the room, Katsuki had to ask a question.

“What does the M stand for?”

Aizawa stopped, turned to him, and looked him dead in the eye. “Migraine Unit.”

Katsuki’s mouth hung open. “Hey, what the fuck is that supposed to mean?”

Aizawa didn’t entertain him with a further explanation. He whipped open the door and immediately the four figures sitting inside stood up and put their hands behind their backs. Katsuki was still stuck on the fucking fact this was *The Migraine Unit* as he looked at the other people in the room and noticed they were all his age.

“Bakugou, I would like for you to meet your new team,” Aizawa said flatly. “Everyone, meet Bakugou Katsuki. He’s going to be joining your squadron for the complex assignments that require multiple people.”

Standing in front of him was the most peculiar bunch Katsuki had ever seen. One canary blond teen with pearly whites and a black streak in his hair waved at him enthusiastically. He had large lightning-colored headphones hanging around his neck while his golden eyes were sparkling with joy.

“First up we have Kaminari Denki,” Aizawa said as he pointed to the canary blond.

“Ayo!” Denki said happily. His voice curled enthusiastically on the ends, and he stared at Katsuki like they were going to be best friends. “Nice to meet you! So glad to have another migraine on the team!”

Aizawa’s eyebrow twitched. “He is unfortunately the lead of electronics and technology of Sector D.”

“How did that happen?” Katsuki mumbled. He tilted his head at the high energy teen in front of him who definitely did not strike Katsuki as ‘computer genius’.

“Oh! This is my favorite story to tell!” Denki chimed. His bright face split into an even more radiant grin as he raised his hand like he was in class. Aizawa actually pointed towards him, letting him take the wheel. “You know those goose viruses? The ones that pop up on your screen and steal your files and then sink your computer afterwards?”

Katsuki cocked his head. “…Yeah?”

“He hacked me,” Aizawa said, irritated. He gritted his teeth. “I was in the middle of sorting through very sensitive case files when suddenly a tiny *goose* appeared on my screen. Next thing I know, the entire Company’s firewall is dropped, and the lights go out.”

“No fucking way.” Katsuki chuckled slightly. “You got hacked by a digital *goose*?”

“That information doesn’t leave this room,” Aizawa snapped quickly. His dark eyes narrowed into thin slits dangerously at Katsuki and Denki. “I immediately hunted down the source thinking it would be a rival agency. But instead, I found Kaminari in his dirty room covered in pizza stains and hentai magazines on the floor with questionable piles of tissue.”

Katsuki scrunched his nose. “That’s disgusting.”

“Very.” Aizawa nodded.

“I hacked them for fun one day.” Denki snickered. “I was trying to prove that they were real! People didn’t believe me when I kept saying there was some secret underground hitman company! It was so cool when Aizawa came into my dorm room yelling—”

“—*Basically,* I was stuck between hiring him or killing him,” Aizawa said tiredly. “No one had ever hacked our systems successfully before, so. I hired him. Better to have that type of intelligence on your side than for it to go to waste.”

“A mistake in many ways,” someone else cut in.

Katsuki cut his eyes towards the person who spoke, and it was a platinum blond with a bored look in his periwinkle eyes. He was dressed in an all-black suit with a baby blue tie with polka dots. A little tacky in Katsuki’s books, but the air of confidence surrounding the other blond was tangible.

“You should have shot Hacker Pikachu in his sleep, Aizawa,” the teen continued. He flipped a coin and grinned cockily. “Solved all our problems.”

“If he shot me, *Monoma*, you wouldn’t have your guy in the chair,” Denki said proudly. He wiggled his eyebrows and grinned wide. “You and Shinsou would’ve failed half the assignments you take without me getting you through security.”

At this, the platinum blond teen now identified as Monoma huffed and rolled his eyes.

“These two are Monoma Neito and Shinsou Hitoshi,” Aizawa said. He gestured to the platinum blond teen and the quiet purple haired teen standing off in the corner. The quieter of the two had a white scarf covering his nose and mouth mysteriously with deep lilac eyes. “The Phantom Killer and The Puppet Master, respectively.”

Katsuki furrowed his brow when the names rang a bell. “Those sounds familiar.”

“They’re nicknames they’ve been given through news outlets,” Aizawa explained. “I tracked these two down through their aliases and got them out of a *very* sticky situation.”

It clicked.

He had heard those names on the news a couple of times over the years. A duo of murderers who hunted people, usually *scummy* people, and were incredibly hard to find. Specifically, The Phantom Killer was the one the news was most interested in. The Puppet Master was more so a theory, a shadow that lurked behind The Phantom Killer because the police suspected it needed to be two people to pull off the murders that were committed.

A trail of goosebumps ignited on Katsuki's skin slightly.

"They're serial killers," Katsuki murmured.

"That's only how it's been framed through the media," Monoma cut down. He leaned against the white table and cocked his head. "Hitoshi and I were orphans who grew up together. The orphanage we were at wasn't the best…I decided we needed to get out. We got recruited by a different hitman company very young because we were tired of the abuse. We never kill for fun or maliciousness like typical serial killers. But we were trained there to immolate famous dead serial killers to throw off the tracks. So, it looks as though phantoms or puppet masters are committing the crimes."

"Journalists go crazy about those types of things," Shinsou said without much emotion on his face. He pulled up his phone and opened a small article to show Katsuki. "Headline 'Ghosts Can Kill: Who is Pulling the Strings?' for the fourth time this month."

Katsuki blinked.

Interesting. They were like him; they did this to survive too.

"Why did you leave your other company?" Katsuki asked.

"We killed our old supervisor," Monoma explained with a tight smile. "We found out he was abusing children. After that, I decided he had to go. Shinsou agreed with me."

"Neither of us are fans of abusers, especially people who hurt children," Shinsou said plainly and shrugged. "Plus, the pay here is better."

Katsuki couldn't argue with that. He nodded in a subtle approval and probed his tongue into his cheek. He then turned to the last person in the room. It was a tall, lanky guy with deep black hair similar to Aizawa's. He had a giant grin with a couple of crooked teeth and kind brown eyes.

"And I'm Sero!" The dark-haired teen said, joyfully. "Nice to meet you, Bakugou!"

Aizawa tilted his head. "Sero is my nephew for full disclosure."

"You hired a family member?" Katsuki exclaimed in surprise.

"Yes. He's a bit of a loner," Aizawa said. His voice was laced with some level of pity. "He never really had friends growing up due to his…*morbid* interests and I'm his favorite family

member. Unfortunately, that means he likes to hang out with me. We wound up here in a series of annoying events."

"I blackmailed him into hiring me," Sero clarified. His face split into a grin and he gave two thumbs up. "I wanted to go over and hang out with him after a bad day at school. But when I got to his house, some dudes busted in like some James Bond movie! My uncle here killed them easily and I helped him hide the evidence with my rad knowledge of how to get rid of bodies."

Katsuki stared at Sero's grinning face in pure bafflement. "…You just *knew* how to get rid of bodies?"

"I know over a thousand ways to dispose of a body," Sero said proudly. Katsuki grew uncomfortable when Sero leaned in a little too eagerly to him and whispered, "the most fun way is with acid."

Katsuki frowned so hard he was sure he gave himself permanent wrinkles.

"Like I said, he has morbid interests," Aizawa said tiredly. "Denki is our hacker. Sero is body clean up. You, Monoma and Shinsou are going to be the main men on the ground. Combined, you five should be a perfect squad for executing perfectly complicated assignments."

"What's his deal though?" Monoma interjected. He inspected Katsuki up and down and raised an unimpressed brow. "How did you take pity on blondie number three to wind up here in your guilt trip unit?"

Aizawa didn't answer, he turned towards Katsuki to speak.

The look he was giving Katsuki was as soft as Aizawa could muster. It translated 'only speak if you want to'. Katsuki took the hint and he found himself feeling a little guarded about himself. He had never had to open up before to anyone, much less a homicidal group of teens.

Katsuki settled for the most concise version of his story. "I killed one of Aizawa's men when I was fourteen. Instead of killing me, he hired me in place of him to pay off the debt. I actually like the job, so I stuck around."

Aizawa raised a brow at the thinly stretched truth.

Denki, Shinsou and Sero seemed to take the reasoning and nodded.

However, Monoma was giving Katsuki a scrutinizing stare. His eyes dug into Katsuki in a way that contradicted the softness of his eye color. They locked eyes for a moment and Katsuki could have sworn he saw a familiar dark look on Monoma's face. He realized at that moment that Monoma was the most similar to him.

Monsters recognized monsters, Katsuki supposed.

"Neat!" Denki said happily. "So we got three killers on the team! I'm okay with this. I somehow feel a lot safer now."

“Why would you feel safer with *more* killers on the team?” Shinsou questioned slowly.

Before Denki could give his, no doubt, long winded answer, Aizawa cleared his throat. He held up five green folders in his hand and it drew everyone’s attention.

“As much as I would *love* to hear the explanation behind that, I have an assignment for you five,” Aizawa said sarcastically. He started to distribute the folders accordingly and each one was stamped with each teen’s respective name. “There’s a client abroad who needs some level of protection, but he also needs some people taken out while he’s in town.”

As Aizawa handed out the folders, Katsuki noted his new ‘team’. But more specifically, he noted the color of the lanyards around their necks that held their ID cards. Sero and Denki’s were yellow. Shinsou and Monoma’s were red. Katsuki glanced down at his own lanyard and noted it was green. Each of the folders they were given matched their lanyard colors.

“Denki and Sero, you’re going for technical support,” Aizawa explained as everyone cracked open their folders. “Shinsou and Monoma, you’re going to take out the individuals listed and Bakugou, you’re on bodyguard duty for the mark who requested the hit.”

“Why am I always on bodyguard duty?” Katsuki questioned.

Everyone turned to him, surprised he had spoken up.

“I make my calls accordingly,” Aizawa said. His tone was short, giving no room for argument as he continued to explain the assignment. “Now, back to what I was saying.”

Katsuki bit his tongue. He attempted to ignore that part of himself that was jealous of the red lanyards around Monoma’s and Shinsou’s necks. He fucking knew green wasn’t *bad* but he felt like he wasn’t being taken serious. As they all sat down at the table, Aizawa explained the intricacies of the assignment. Katsuki couldn’t stop glaring at the paper in front of him. He counted the 0s attached to the payment number happily, but he hated how his folder was green.

He pushed down the bitter, dark part of him and decided to focus on the good.

This assignment was in Taiwan.

He had never been there before, maybe this could be fun.

☽ ☽ ☽

Taiwan was beautiful. The air was clean, fresh and filled his lungs with a feeling he wished he could take back home with him. The five of them had landed in the new country with their suits and guns ready to go.

Their client this time was a young adult by the name of Chih-wei Tang. He had a bright, charming smile and a shining personality to match.

Chih-wei was fluent in Japanese and knew how to really lay on the charm, and he didn’t actually seem that bad. The issue with this assignment though, despite how nice the man was,

he had a past history of drug smuggling for notorious, less nice people. Chih-wei acted like a port to get contraband in and out of China, Japan, and surrounding countries and Asia without being on the radar too much since he wasn't a big name.

However, in recent years, many of his old clientele were realizing he had mixed their drug of choice with filler substance and kept the real half for himself. In short, he was stealing from dangerous men.

After years of setting up his own drug ring, Chih-wei had a large beach house in Taiwan where he hosted big parties. He was the talk of the town and if you got an invite from Chih-wei, then you were as good as gold.

But, if Katsuki was able to give his opinion, he'd say this man was stupid.

Who the hell would invite people into their house when there were drug lords who were looking to chop his head off? But he guessed that's what they were there for. Guarding some man who *had* to have a mansion full of people drinking and laughing.

When the night of the assignment came, the party that was thrown was the most lavish thing Katsuki had ever witnessed. Part of him was intrigued, the other half was revolted. This was wasteful as shit. Drunk men and women were running all over, jumping in the pool, and flirting. All of the service people were dressed in skimpy, knockoff playboy bunny outfits with fishnets. The service folks were all outrageously attractive, serving everyone green drinks and wine bottles with dazzling sparklers in them.

"This isn't exactly the scene I would have guessed for our first assignment together," Shinsou commented when they walked in.

The five of them stood there, clearly sore thumbs in the crowd. Silver and gold confetti rained down on them as pop music played in the background. Unlike all the half nude party goers, they were all dressed in black suits. Katsuki muttered unhappily as he shrugged off his blazer and threw it over his broad shoulders. He ran a hand through his hair and pushed back his bangs a bit.

Fucking body heat. The mansion was too stuffy for Aizawa's 'hitman dress code' bullshit. As they stood there awkwardly, several drunk people caught sight of Katsuki and winked at him with curled fingers.

Katsuki blanched. "I hate this place already."

"Think of it like team bonding!" Denki suggested. He propped his designer sunglasses on his head with a big grin. His eyes crawled over the mansion like he was in heaven. "Whoa, this place is amazing. I swear this is the exact bunny waiter outfit I've seen in a lot of my adult online games."

Katsuki scoffed at Denki and shook his head.

"Please don't say that to anyone," Monoma groaned. "I know you have a porn addiction, pikachu, so don't say anything weird to the servers tonight or I'm shooting you on sight."

“My special guests! Welcome!” Chih-wei greeted them with his handsome smile.

He was dressed the exact opposite of the hitmen with a half-unbuttoned leopard print silk blouse and gold chain. He coupled this with crisp white pants and pointed gator shoes that were far more fashionable than Katsuki ever would have guessed.

“Thank you so much for coming,” Chih-wei said with a cool air. “I really appreciate you all being here tonight so I can enjoy the alignment of the stars to the fullest! I want to always make sure to respect the constellations.”

“You’re throwing a raging party because of astrology?” Shinsou clarified. He raised a thin brow and crossed his arms. “Seems a bit wasteful.”

“Fate is nothing to take lightly.” Chih-wei laughed and playfully hit Shinsou’s shoulder. “I read in the astrology books today that this is the day we will run into our fate. It could be a person, money, or even death. But fate is gracing us this afternoon. So what better way to celebrate it than with an amazing party! Come! I have saved seats for you in my VIP section.”

Chih-wei laughed and talked with them all the way to the part of his house that was even more packed.

It was a large, open area with an indoor pool and maroon velvet couches stacked all around. One section was heavily guarded with men in black with earpieces and their guns were very much visible on their sides. When they finally sat down in the VIP section with Chih-wei, the man served them nothing but the finest of party foods and liquor.

They sat there all night chatting with him, discussing his private jet and all his adventures. Denki and Sero were the most interested while Shinsou and Monoma were slightly standoffish about it.

Katsuki however, had tuned it out.

He had a certain disdain for the ultra-wealthy, and all he could see around him was bill money being wasted. He glanced at all the people and wondered if this is how Chih-wei lived every day. However, as he was trying to figure out where the confetti was falling from, Katsuki’s sights caught on one particular bunny server whose back was turned towards him.

His eyebrows shot up and a blush rose on his face.

Well, damn.

Standing on the other side of the large pool serving drinks was a male server who was slightly bent over. His back was perfectly arched with the sexiest ass and legs Katsuki had ever seen. His muscular legs were cladded in tight fishnets and the taut, skimpy outfit gave a little bit of an outline of his manhood. Katsuki struggled to tear his eyes away when the waiter bent over more. The waiter had straight, light blue hair that tapered at his nape. Katsuki couldn’t see how he looked, but he knew an ass like that had to have a cute face to match.

A foreign, hot feeling raced down Katsuki's core when he considered what the sound of ripping fishnets would be like.

"There's a lot of sexy people here," Sero pointed out when Chih-wei's attention was drawn elsewhere.

Monoma didn't bother looking around. "Sure."

"What? You don't think anyone here is cute?" Denki asked.

"I have a girlfriend," Monoma said. He shrugged, not interested in all the tempting people who were packed around them. He turned his sights on Bakugou, who was still staring at the guy across the way. "How about you, Bakugou? Do you have a girlfriend or boyfriend? Or are you single as a Pringle?"

"Judging by the way his eyes keep viciously eye fucking that male waiter, I assume he's single," Shinsou quipped as he sipped his drink. "Or at least I *hope* he is."

"Yeah, I am," Katsuki answered.

He cleared his throat to bring himself back to reality. He eyed that poor waiter's backside a little too hard. But he was just so goddamn *perfect*. He had never seen an ass that perky before without clothes.

Well. He thought back to Vienna and was *horribly* reminded Deku had a cute ass like that.

The bunny waiter bent over to give full fucking view of his manhood area cladded in the leather leotard for the world to see. It stirred a feeling in Katsuki's core he never bothered to touch. But all Katsuki could think about now was running his hands down the smooth, toned skinned man on the other side of the room.

"This is a real *ass*ignment, am I right?" Denki gave a cocksure grin as he ogled the perky backside of the waiter who Katsuki couldn't take his sights off.

"Definitely," Katsuki whispered, dazed. "Emphasis on the ass."

Shinsou shook his head at him in disapproval. "You both are being disrespectful. If you're done eye fucking that guy, you should go up and ask for his name. Like a *gentleman*."

"Gentle probably isn't in Bakugou's vocabulary," Monoma pointed out casually.

He swirled his green drink and cut his eye towards Katsuki. Katsuki cut his eye back.

"What the hell was that supposed to mean?"

"What? Am I wrong?"

"You're not wrong but you're not right either," Katsuki grumbled, deflecting from the discomfort he felt in his chest. Monoma smirked slightly, satisfied with the answer. "I've just

never had to be a gentleman or whatever. Shoot me for thinking the waiter was cute enough to stare at for a while."

"Being a gentleman comes with practice," Shinsou lectured. He smirked at Katsuki and gestured towards the server who was now walking the other direction. "Go ahead, talk to him if you really want to. You're a looker if you haven't noticed, half the people in here turned their heads when you walked by. I'm sure he'll be just as star-stuck. Monoma and I will be here to cover anything that happens and ensure the mark is safe."

"Yeah! Go flirt, Bakugou!" Denki encouraged. "We got everything covered over here."

Katsuki looked unsure, he had never pursued something like this.

Technically he was still a goddamn *virgin* but he wasn't about to let these dunces on his team be aware of that. The young blond threw his head back and took a full shot of vodka down his throat to give him extra confidence. He smoothed out his blond spikes and rid himself fully of his blazer. Sero snickered and undid the first three buttons on his white shirt and Shinsou gave him an encouraging pat on the shoulders.

Katsuki slowly walked over and trailed behind the waiter, practicing what to say in his head. A loud pop song played overhead and he very bluntly ignored the people who tried to grab his attention along the way.

When he finally was directly behind that beautiful ass, Katsuki grinned wide and tapped the guy on the shoulder.

"Hey there," Katsuki greeted in choppy mandarin. He wasn't fluent but he knew enough to try to see if he could get the conversation going. He smirked at the cute blue hair of the waiter who had bunny ears perched on his head. "I know this is weird, but I think you're really damn cute. I wanted to, er, see if you would like to go somewhere a little more private?"

The waiter stiffened at the sound of his voice.

Then like a bad nightmare, the waiter turned around and it was Deku in a fucking wig.

"You?!" Both Katsuki and Deku exclaimed in Japanese.

All hell broke loose as several things happened at once: Katsuki angrily grappled at Deku, but unfortunately grabbed the blue wig in the process. Deku swiftly snatched himself out of Katsuki's grasp and stumbled back in the heels he was in, revealing his real hair color. Green. Green fucking curls were now visible for *everyone* to see. Then in a heartbeat Deku reached down in his leotard and pulled out several little knives and flung them at Katsuki.

Katsuki swiftly dodged the sharp objects as they whistled in the air and tried to stop Deku. But Katsuki ended up punching the other man in the throat instead. Deku made a choking sound and everyone in the surrounding area started screaming and scattered when the deadly little knives plunged into the paintings of Chih-wei on the wall versus into Chih-wei.

Deku swiftly recovered and dropped Katsuki on his back with a full kick, knocking the air out of his lungs.

“What are you doing here!?” Deku demanded, sounding just as shocked as he was.

Katsuki yelled loudly, tripping up Deku and bringing him down to his level. “I should be asking you that, you worthless little—”

He didn’t get to finish that sentence when Deku started trying to stab him with a fang shaped dagger. The other assassin was attempting to go for his jugular, but his movements weren’t as concise as Vienna. Or maybe Katsuki was angrier and more prepared. Whichever it was, they were in a stalemate of dodging punches and knives. Deku was sloppier, and a lot more frantic than before as though he was upset at the sight of Katsuki.

After tussling, Deku clearly gave up. He grunted loudly in frustration and ran off into the quickly dispersing crowd. Katsuki cursed under his breath when he realized this little fucker was probably here to kill his mark.

Katsuki stood up as well when Deku started going at high speed into the room with the VIP section. Katsuki followed hot on his heels, screaming for his colleagues to get to their designated safe zone. He waved his hands frantically to signal trouble, and Shinsou and Monoma pulled out their guns. Sero and Denki quickly rushed Chih-wei out of the VIP section and they all formed a wall of protection around their mark.

Katsuki pushed the lavish party goers out of his way as he chased behind Deku, landing many of them into the indoor pool. It was then Katsuki realized Deku was trying to lose him in some rabid goose chase. The shorter man was running at full speed in fucking *heels* towards his mark. Katsuki cursed when he realized the little fucker was probably trying to find a way to get to Chih-wei now that he had been exposed.

“Get fucking back here!” Katsuki screamed as Deku started running up a flight of stairs.

“Leave me alone!” Deku screamed back, angrily glaring over his shoulders. “I told you to stay out of my way!” Deku moved like goddamn liquid in the crowd, like a ballet dancer who was fluid on his toes. He ran up the stairs to where Chih-wei had been escorted but Katsuki wasn’t about to have it.

When Deku was up the stairs, Katsuki took a chance and aimed his gun at Deku. He rapidly fired off two shots, making bystanders nearby scream in horror. Deku ducked and quickly used some unsuspecting party goer as a human shield to make Katsuki stop his fire. The blond hitman cursed loudly when he saw the trembling face of the woman who was clearly scared for her life.

Katsuki started to run up the stairs, closing in on the other hitman, but the moment he got close he was swiftly hit upside the head with a heel. Before he had the chance to process, Deku had thrown his goddamn shoes at him, Katsuki was hit again, but this time square in the fucking eye. He had no clue the point of a goddamn heel could hurt so badly.

Katsuki cursed loudly when suddenly he was kicked in the head and forced backwards.

Deku tackled him, and everyone in the room cleared out when the tiny assassin pulled out even more knives. Deku looked ready to kill, but Katsuki checkmated him and quickly grabbed his wrists. Everything after that was a struggle that Katsuki would soon find familiar. Deku punched him. Katsuki kicked him. Deku bit him. Katsuki slammed him against the wall. Deku tried to slice his throat and Katsuki tried to choke him to death.

They went back and forth, knocking over all the glass vases and expensive items in the house. Eventually, Katsuki gained the upper hand and he slammed Deku's head against the pretty white marble until the other assassin looked dizzy. Green eyes were wide, and the man looked like he was going to be seasick.

He looked just like Hiryu did against the floor, and that one memory caused Katsuki to wrap both his hands around Deku's throat and squeeze. The other hitman grunted in surprise and looked up at him as he began to squirm.

"I'm going to *kill* you for what you did to Hiryu," Katsuki promised with a sneer.

Anger swelled in his chest until it was about to explode. It was hot, scathing with rage. He could see the haunting visual of Hiryu bleeding out on the rooftop in Vienna. It fueled his passionate hate for the green menace underneath him. His monsters oozed out of him like thick, dark liquid as he forced his way between Deku's legs and tightened his grip around his slender throat.

Deku whimpered slightly and scratched at his hands as he was pinned down.

Katsuki put his whole weight on the small man, trying to force him to stop squirming. He wanted him dead for what he had done. But the pressure only made Deku squirm more. The smaller body under him was bucking, trying to throw him off and the feeling of the leather leotard against his pants created an unwanted, new friction Katsuki hadn't felt before. The bucking made him feel hot, and hotter until he found himself bucking back. He pulled a soft gasp from Deku's pretty pink lips.

Katsuki's nerves started to tingle the more he met Deku's bucking. He thought the hot feeling was hatred—but it was different. It felt more addictive and…*good*?

Katsuki snapped his eyes down.

Deku's fishnet cladded thighs spread out under him looked far different than he thought it would.

Then Deku struggled once more, letting out a gasping sound that was a little too pleasant to his ears. The smaller man grunted desperately as he reached down for something. Then directly followed was the sound of ripping fishnets and it gripped Katsuki at the bottom of his stomach.

Without warning, the vision of Deku's pretty doll face gasping underneath him made all the blood in Katsuki rush downwards.

He froze.

His grip loosened just enough for Deku to gasp for air. They stared at each other for a moment and the heat in his belly coiled tightly, ready to snap.

Then like a switch, Deku's blushing doll face twisted into a venomous snarl, and he lurched forward. Katsuki yelled in pain when Deku head butted him with all his damn strength. The young blond grabbed at his head when he felt a rush of dizziness and the small man scrambled from underneath him. Deku then swiftly kicked him in the head, knocking him against the wall and ran off out of the house.

Katsuki groaned from the blow and curled on the ground.

Deku. Fucking Deku again. How the hell was this possible?

His dizzy vision blended together Hiryu and the green little shit stain in his brain and frowned. He tried to get up and go chase him to avenge his friend—but his stomach felt queasy.

He was going to fucking hurl from the incoming storm of a headache.

"Bakugou!" Shinsou's voice said from behind him. Katsuki struggled to turn his head, but when he did he could see Shinsou and Denki armed with their handguns glancing around. "Did you get the guy? Where did he go?"

"He fucking got away," Katsuki grumbled. He struggled to stand up, wobbly as he clutched his head. He was angry with himself and downright pissed off that Deku once again got away. "He went the direction of the back yard; we can still chase him if there's time—"

"—Whoa," Denki whispered, chuckling. "Dude. Holy shit."

"What?" Katsuki snapped. "Why are you still standing there and fucking laughing? Go chase him!"

Shinsou pinched the bridge of his nose and turned away from Katsuki like he accidentally saw something he wasn't supposed to. The purple haired teen lowered his gun and shook his head and Denki started to laugh like a maniac. Katsuki leaned against the wall, trying to steady himself from his spinning vision. When his world stopped tilting, Katsuki glanced down and realized what was wrong.

He had a full-blown fucking erection.

☽ ☽ ☽

"Explain this to me again slowly. The assassin you saw in Vienna was now in Taiwan dressed in a playboy bunny outfit?" Aizawa asked like Katsuki was stupid. "Surely, you're joking."

The flustered blond teen wanted to pull his hair out.

They were back in Japan in their headquarters and all Katsuki wanted to do was track down the goddamn green pest. He could still hear and feel Deku's goddamn body against his, and he didn't understand *why*.

“I’m not joking!” Katsuki exclaimed. He gestured wildly to the other teens in the room who were holding in snickers about the situation. “He was there, and he was trying to kill our mark, but I stopped him.”

Denki’s snicker burst out into a hearty laugh. “Yeah, with your large *boner*. I don’t think I’ve ever seen someone with a dick outline that big you probably scared him off with that thing __”

Katsuki shoved Denki out of his chair before he could finish that sentence. Denki yelped as he went toppling over and Aizawa pinched the bridge of his nose to prevent an oncoming headache.

“Back to the topic,” Aizawa grumbled. “If this is the same agent from Vienna, then we might have a problem. Can any of you draw out what he looked like on the board?”

“Sure thing,” Shinsou agreed.

The lavender hair teen stood up and walked over to the front of the conference room. He picked up one of the old, scratchy dry erase markers and drew one of the worst portraits Katsuki had ever seen. His colleague made Deku’s face way too fucking square and he didn’t bother to capture his big ass eyes. Then he only put like eight dots on his face.

“He had more freckles than that,” Katsuki grumbled, slightly flustered.

Everyone’s head turned towards him.

Aizawa opened his mouth, then shut it. Monoma and Sero chuckled under their breath and said some sly shit Katsuki couldn’t hear. He glared at them all for making fun of him. But what was worse was how his hammering heart was consistently speeding up as he stared at the stupidly drawn picture of Deku on the board.

Aizawa shook his head like he didn’t get paid enough for this. “Well. The assignment was completed is all that matters. You all can go, except you, Bakugou. You stay behind, I have something to speak to you about.”

Sero patted him on the shoulder. “Don’t get too turned on by the sexy picture Shinsou drew while you’re talking to the boss.”

“I’ll fucking skin you alive,” Katsuki said from his gritted teeth. His face was burning in embarrassment.

His four colleagues laughed in unison, winking at him and whispering crude jokes. Aizawa didn’t react, pointedly ignoring all the sexual innuendos the teens were making about what had transpired on their first assignment together. When the door clicked shut, Aizawa reached from the bottom of the large stack of papers he had on the glass table.

He pulled out a red folder.

Katsuki raised an eyebrow.

Aizawa fiddled with it for a little while.

“You’ve been doing green folder assignments for a couple of years,” Aizawa muttered slowly. “I wanted to see how you would perform on a green folder assignment that required a bit more intent to kill if needed with the Taiwan assignment.”

“And how did I do?” Katsuki asked, trying to mask his eagerness.

“You did good,” Aizawa said. Katsuki resisted grinning like a fool. “Outside of the whole mystery assassin issue, you did a good job at thinking with your head. I was half expecting you to try to murder the guy, but you didn’t. Which I can respect because it shows restraint. So. I think you’re ready for a red folder assignment now.”

Katsuki wanted to correct him. He did in fact, want to murder Deku. Only reason he hadn’t was because the damn guy was just as skilled if not more skilled than he was. And, er, his situation prevented him from doing any heavy chasing.

But he took the small win.

Aizawa handed him the scarlet envelope with a look of approval.

Katsuki reached for it, and it was heavy in his hands. His heart raced at the prospect of the thrill. It was odd. Finally holding the very thing he’d seen others with for the last four years and now it was finally in his hands. The hungry side of him was rumbling in anticipation as Katsuki opened the folder slowly.

Inside he saw a photo of a man he didn’t know or recognize. He looked like a normal guy to be honest. Katsuki tilted his head because he had been anticipating someone a little gruffer seeming. He looked over the details and there was nothing exactly incriminating either. A simple kill order by a private client.

“What did he do?” Katsuki couldn’t help but ask.

“Nothing that we know,” Aizawa replied, utterly detached. “A mark is a mark. That’s all.”

Concise as always.

Katsuki never considered that the red folder assignments would be like this. Just a name, a photo, and little details. Far less personal than green folders where you had to get to know the person you were protecting. On top of the man’s photograph was the amount Katsuki would be getting paid after The Company took their share. It was a larger amount than any green or yellow assignment. The amount of commas in the numbers appealed to Katsuki as he thought about all the things he could buy for him and his mother.

Er—for *him*. Not for him and his mother.

Katsuki furrowed his brows. What a bad fucking reflex.

“When do I need to be on the ground?” Katsuki asked.

“We have a forty-eight-hour window to complete the hit,” Aizawa explained easily. “After you finish it off, I’ll transfer you the money once the negotiations are fully complete. Remember to kill from a place of necessity and not passion. Passionate killing is never good. We need to be surgical.”

Katsuki nodded. “Right.”

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki thought this might feel different, but it didn't.

It felt like a regular Wednesday night, and he wasn’t sure if he liked that. Currently, he was stationed on some dusty roof top in all black with a sniper gun. He had a gaiter mask concealing half of his face as his spikes blew in the wind. It was dark outside, cloaking him in further camouflage in this random neighborhood he had never stepped foot in.

The summer breeze was annoyingly refreshing. It gave him some relief from the feeling of suffocating in his all-black attire. He was waiting patiently for his mark to come home from work. Despite being told not to, Katsuki had done snooping and looked up where the man worked. He was an engineer for some tech company and spent his whole life working in HTML and JAVA script code. Katsuki tried to create fake scenarios in his head as to why this man was wanted dead.

But the worst realization was when Katsuki understood there didn’t have to be a reason. This could be as simple as a grudge. Or an ex-spouse. Or even something like ‘I didn’t like the way that guy looked at me this one time’.

There didn’t always have to be reasoning behind killing—Katsuki just had to do as he was asked.

A mark was a mark.

He stayed there, and he never tore his eyes away from the dark window apartment.

Then the moment arrived.

The lights clicked on and all the adrenaline in Katsuki’s body surged.

He calmly grabbed his sniper rifle and looked through the glass. He could see the magnified image of his mark with the red target sitting on top of him. Katsuki took a moment to study the man, and guess what his life was like. The mark was a middle-aged man who looked like he had just gotten off of work. He was dressed in a white button up and blue tie with round glasses that were taped in the middle. His pants still had the tag on them, and he scratched an odd rash on his neck.

Katsuki frowned a bit the longer he studied this stranger.

He was ordinary. Plain. A regular man who seemed tired from the labors of capitalism on his body.

Katsuki fiddled a bit with the trigger, waiting for a sense of glee to come. But it never did. Instead, he remained completely empty like a ship casted off to sea with no passengers. When his mark raked his hand through his dark colored hair, Katsuki realized he was thinking about this too hard. He sucked in a deep breath and refocused.

A mark is a mark.

When the man loosened his tie slightly, Katsuki pulled the trigger.

The bullet was swift.

It cut through the glass, shattering it and leaving a pattern like spiderwebs on the window. It flew true and plunged into one of the man's temples and exited through the other.

The body dropped to the ground immediately and red was splattered on the white wall.

A clean kill. Virtually painless from what Katsuki had researched.

Katsuki removed his eyes from the looking glass and refocused on the window. It seemed so far away now. Then suddenly a scratching feeling knocked against the back of his brain. His burning curiosity wanted to make sure the man was dead, or at least that's what he told himself.

When he viewed through the looking glass again, he saw a small child standing over the man's body. It was a tiny boy, looking confused as he poked at the lifeless body on the ground. Katsuki's face and heart dropped. He quickly snatched his vision away from peering inside the window.

A father.

The man was a father.

A strange feeling gnawed at the inside of Katsuki's gut. The trigger under his finger suddenly felt cold.

☽ ☽ ☽

"So. How did you feel about it?" Aizawa asked curiously.

Katsuki was currently sitting in his supervisor's office looking at the picture of Koji on his desk. The blond teen was silent. He didn't exactly know how to answer that question. His mind replayed that visual of the small child standing over their father's dead body. He kept visualizing himself inside of the apartment, or as the bullet itself. He only had viewed it through the window—but what if the kid had seen his father drop dead?

"I felt…" Katsuki started. He was unsure what he was experiencing. He was numb, analyzing every little detail until the repetition made it feel meaningless. "…Indifferent? Or. I don't know. I don't feel bad, but I don't feel great either."

Aizawa nodded in approval. "Good. That's the sweet spot."

“What do you mean?” Katsuki asked. He stared at Aizawa strangely.

“Detachment is what you’re feeling,” Aizawa clarified. “It’s good for this job. You shouldn’t be excited to kill or feel any gratification when you put a bullet in a man who seemed utterly innocent. But you also shouldn’t be riddled with guilt because I need you to be on top of your game.”

“Oh.” Katsuki hadn’t thought of it like that. “Detached I guess is the right word.”

“Yes.” Aizawa leaned back in his chair as he flipped through some files. Katsuki counted the number of red versus green folders. There were about twelve reds. Which meant it could be twelve fathers. “This is the exact news you want to get. It means you’re not a psychopathic serial killer but you’re also not dead weight to me.”

“What happens now?” Katsuki asked.

“You start living the way you want to live.” Aizawa gave him a small smile. “Red assignments pay well. I have a couple more red requests that were put on my desk today. I’ll shuffle through them and give you however many you think you can stomach for the week. If there’s something that I think requires the M-Unit I will make sure to call you all here together, but otherwise go get some rest and rebound, Bakugou.”

“Sure.” Katsuki nodded numbly. “Will do.”

He stood up from the desk and did exactly as he was told.

He went home to his empty, lavish apartment. As he flipped through the TV he landed on some random show he had never heard of. It was a show with a family. A loving father and mother and their three children.

Katsuki sat and watched it that night, chest hollowed out.

☽ ☽ ☽

The next day after his first red folder assignment, Katsuki told Aizawa he needed a breather. He didn’t know why he had asked for it, the assignment itself was anticlimactic in an impossible way. But he still felt like he needed it. Aizawa easily agreed, as if expecting him to call in.

Katsuki found himself wandering like a ghost around the city.

He had barely ever walked around or took the time out to observe. People of all sorts walked by him. Mothers. Fathers. People who were possibly aunts and uncles. There were many people his age, clustered up together in groups that glowed with social butterfly energy. They looked like university students, and Katsuki pictured another version of himself in uni with these groups of friends.

Soon, his feet started to lead him to his mother’s apartment. He knew he should have called or even announced that he was coming to visit her after such a long stretch of silence between them. But he didn’t bother.

On the way there, a tiny flower shop caught his eye.

In the window were beautiful, pink carnations.

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki nervously knocked on his mother's apartment door. He stared down at the flowers in his hands, restless a little bit. It took a minute for any sort of sound to rustle from behind the door. The pessimistic part of Katsuki was experiencing preemptive disgust. His mother was probably inside drinking or gambling. Probably throwing away all the goddamn money he was sending her. The other part of Katsuki was foolishly hopeful and reminded him he loved his mother.

When the door opened, Katsuki realized he wasn't sure what he was doing here.

Mitsuki looked equally as stunned.

Mother and son stared at each other for a moment. Katsuki cleared his throat and scratched behind his head. He peered around her curiously and was surprised to find an empty apartment. Freshly cleaned too with the smell of Pine-Sol wafting in the air.

"Well, someone finally decided to come check on their mother," Mitsuki said sarcastically. She raised a brow at her son and leaned her weight onto one hip. "I've been leaving you all sorts of voicemails and texts. I was starting to think you changed your number."

"Sorry, I was just busy with work," Katsuki deflected. He shrugged, deciding not to feel guilty about neglecting her and her chaos. "I, uh, brought you flowers. I noticed you liked this kind."

Mitsuki reached forward and smiled forcefully. "Pink carnations, yeah. They're my favorite."

She took the flowers in her hand and they both exchanged strained smiles. Mitsuki waited for Katsuki to leave and half of Katsuki waited for it as well. But his feet were glued in place when he thought about the child from last night standing over their dead father.

"Can I come in?" Katsuki quickly asked.

Mitsuki's eyes lit up slightly and she stepped to the side. "Of course."

Katsuki walked inside her apartment for the first time since he moved out. It was exactly how he left it but instead of the mess he was subjected to every day, it was clean. Polished. Shit was put together well. He churned slightly with bitterness and didn't even want to know if the fridge actually had food in it.

As he passed by inside the living room, he noticed a single overdue bill sitting on the countertop.

But instead of being upset, he was indifferent. Just like he had been when he pulled that trigger. He turned towards his mother who had caught sight of him assessing the late bill on the countertop. She smiled at him and quickly moved it out of sight as he walked around the

open space. Neither of them mentioned that tiny elephant in the room as she began to put the flowers into a vase.

“How come pink carnations are your favorite?” Katsuki asked as he sat down at the dining table casually.

“My mother used to grow them in our garden,” Mitsuki answered. She smiled fondly at the flowers. “She would always keep a fresh vase in the room for me.”

Katsuki perked up a bit at that.

His mother usually never discussed her family. It was always off limits with a quick ‘you’re too young to ever understand’ to deflect from his question. But he curiously studied how his mother’s gaze had potent adoration when she looked at the flowers.

“Do…Do we have other family members?” Katsuki asked.

“No,” Mitsuki answered a bit too quickly. “No one that I am aware of anyways.”

“Ah.”

Katsuki tried his best to hide his disappointment.

Mitsuki glanced over her shoulder at him with a soft smile. She walked over to him at the kitchen table with the glass vase in her hands. She gently placed it down on the dining room table he had purchased for them a long time ago and she fluffed the flowers.

“If you really want to know, my parents and I lost touch before you were born,” Mitsuki said. She tilted her head at Katsuki with an apologetic smile. “When I tried to reach back out, I couldn’t find them. Masaru and I assumed they must’ve passed away because I can’t figure out where they went. Or anyone who might know. If they were alive I’m sure they would have loved the chance to meet you.”

Katsuki nodded, accepting that explanation.

A part of him melted in his chilling defenses, and Mitsuki could tell. Katsuki couldn’t deny he missed his mother; he had needed the breather, but he didn’t know until now he just needed to know who he was. Where he came from. Who exactly was he related to? His mother talked a lot about herself but never her background.

Mitsuki gently touched the pink carnations, thumbing the petals softly.

“I’m sorry I never told you who your real biological father was, Katsuki,” Mitsuki muttered. Pain struck across her face. “You deserved to know who it was. I shouldn’t have kept that from you.”

“It’s alright,” Katsuki muttered. He looked away from her. “I know you were just trying to protect me.”

“I was but in the process I hurt you and pushed you away.” Mitsuki hung her head. “I miss you, Katsuki. I’m sorry.”

Those two words hit him in a place Katsuki thought didn’t exist: his heart.

He crumbled under the weight of the simple phrases: I miss you. I’m sorry. So small yet so powerful and more than he realized he needed to hear. Katsuki nodded and tried to push back the feeling of tears in his eyes.

“I missed you too, mom,” Katsuki said. He felt like a child here with her in the worst way.

“Let’s not go that long without talking again, okay? It’s only us in this world together. We don’t have anyone else. We shouldn’t be angry at each other,” Mitsuki whispered. “I never want to hurt you, Katsuki. That’s never my intention. I-I’ve been getting better—really this time. I feel better. I do things timelier. I even quit gambling for good. But I recognize I haven’t been entirely fair to you. If there’s any questions you have, I’ll answer them.”

He smiled gently at his mother, feeling slightly mended. He nodded and decided to ask a question that had been burning in his mind before Vienna.

“Did you love Imasuji Goto?” Katsuki wearily asked.

“Of course,” Mitsuki answered easily. She laughed lightheartedly and smiled. “I loved that bastard very much. We dated for years after I moved out from the countryside and into the city. I really loved how exciting the city life was.”

“Then why did you date him when he was some known gangster?”

Mitsuki shrugged. “When I met him, I didn’t realize who he was, and he didn’t exactly announce that he was an underground crime lord. Sure, I had heard of some gangster by the alias of Muscular, but I didn’t make the connection he *was* Muscular, y’know? I just saw a handsome man who was chasing me.”

Katsuki pursed his lips. “You never found out?”

“I did,” Mitsuki confessed softly. “But by that point, I loved him. It’s hard to let go of things you love. I started…embracing his lifestyle, or at least bits of it. He introduced me to drinking, gambling, and some level of fun contraband use. I’m not going to lie and say I didn’t have fun, because I partied like there was no damn tomorrow. But I suppose that was the problem. I barely went home to see my parents after that. Then one day—I found out I was pregnant.”

Katsuki felt a pang of unwanted guilt.

“I had never considered being a mom before, but I really liked the idea when I thought of it,” Mitsuki said. She looked at Katsuki with love and pinched his cheek. “A little mini me, running around. It would be so cute. I asked him what he would think about us being parents but of course, he laughed in my face.” Now his mother made a disgusted expression. “The

bastard wasn't interested in being a father and he very bluntly told me I would make a terrible mother."

"What an asshole," Katsuki muttered flippantly.

He expected his mother to laugh or make a joke—but she hadn't. She smiled at him sadly.

"I suppose he was right in the end though, huh," Mitsuki murmured. "I have been a terrible mother."

Immediately Katsuki rebounded. "No, you're not. You're trying your best."

"Sometimes best isn't always enough, Katsuki."

They stared at each other. The sound of the leaky faucet from the kitchen trickled in. Katsuki broke eye contact and pulled at his pants.

"What happened after that?" Katsuki muttered.

He didn't lift his eyes from his lap and instead focused on a single loose thread in his pants. He plucked at it to relieve some tension in his hands as his mother grew silent. He expected some regular answer, one that involved him being born and Muscular not wanting to be involved. However, instead he was greeted with an answer that he didn't know how to accept.

"I told him I was pregnant, and he attempted to beat me into having a miscarriage."

Katsuki whipped his head up. "*What*?"

"He didn't want to be a father," Mitsuki explained bitterly. A dark cloud overshadowed her eyes and she scowled deeply at whatever memory was burning hot inside of her. "I tried to get help, but I couldn't. My parents were too—they were too busy, and they were *strict*. I just wanted to live my life happily with my baby. So, I ran away. I met Masaru shortly after and he was the love of my life. I wish you got to know him better than you did because he really was a walking angel."

His mother kept going.

She kept talking but Katsuki was stuck on the goddamn fact his mother had been beaten.

By fucking *Muscular,* nonetheless.

His mom kept talking, speeding past that horrifying tidbit of information like it was a small disagreement. Katsuki masked his concern the best he could, but it was hard. Every time the faucet dripped in the background he could see that blurry footage of Muscular appear in his mind. He could see his scarlet painted smile and visually see the villain of his mother's story.

His depraved shadow rumbled. It whispered and furiously demanded retribution as it reared its ugly head to him. That's when it clicked: why his first red folder assignment was so anticlimactic. It was because the man hadn't been scum. Katsuki enjoyed ridding the earth of scum—but that man in the window wasn't such a person.

Imasuji Goto, however, was.

☽ ☽ ☽

Months went by and slowly Mitsuki and Katsuki's relationship mended.

They felt like mother and son again with the tiny things like going out to the movies. Some days his mother invited him over for dinner and they laughed and talked like Katsuki wasn't a certified killer. Every Friday he gave her money to pay her bills and he tried to tell himself it was up to her to make sure she actually paid it.

But sometimes, Katsuki could see a late bill poorly hidden around her apartment.

She was acting more stable, like she used to sometimes. He was worried she would slip again, and the concept of late bills was hard for him to accept. He started to take it upon himself to make sure her bills were paid himself. She seemed thankful for this and would be happy for him to take charge of her finances.

During this, Katsuki received red folder after red folder.

Each time he pulled the trigger, he felt close to nothing and Aizawa praised him for it. Detachment was key and the money stacked higher than he could ever imagine. He was beginning to feel well established for once in his life as he started buying himself finer things.

He splurged on suits, and he loved the look of himself in the color black. Every morning he went to work at The Company in his best clothes and leather jacket he had grown attached to. He could see some people check him out as he grew into his frame more. He would smirk cockily at the people he could catch looking at him. It was fun to send experimental flirtatious winks and it went straight to his head whenever he was able to make some cute girl or guy blush.

Katsuki loved the way they fucking swooned.

Maybe it was the self-centered part of him that enjoyed the attention for once.

He continued this routine for six months. Then the cycle was broken one day in Aizawa's office.

Katsuki had his legs kicked up, spreading all over Aizawa's couch while his supervisor glared at him. The arrogant young blond was biting into an apple and chewing it loudly as Aizawa was assigning out the folders for the red assignments. Monoma was in the room with him as well, disgusted with the way Katsuki was devouring the apple.

"Do you *have* to eat like a pig while we wait?" Monoma snapped.

Katsuki smirked and gave another big crunch into the fruit. "Being a little agitating is just in my nature."

Monoma inhaled deeply and counted to ten under his breath. The other blond crossed his arms and rolled his eyes. Aizawa stood up at that moment with two folders in hand and then walked over to both of them. His shoulders were slouched forward as he distributed the folders.

“Here are your assignments for the week,” Aizawa said tiredly. “Both of these are time sensitive and also require an insane amount of discretion. Nothing to draw attention. Snipe from a building and call it a day. Make sure no one sees you.”

Katsuki and Monoma both opened their folders.

Katsuki looked over his assignment. Some rando again. He didn’t give it too much of a second glance after deciding the pay was enough for him. He gave Aizawa a thumbs up and looked towards Monoma whose face was painted in surprise. His periwinkle eyes blinked rapidly and glanced up to Katsuki before quickly looking away. He closed his folder shut and cleared his throat.

“Will do,” Monoma said firmly.

Aizawa gave them both nods of approval and dismissed them.

As they were walking out of Aizawa’s office with gleaming red folders, Katsuki couldn’t help but think Monoma’s reaction was odd.

“So. Who was in your folder?” Katsuki pried.

“Are you seriously asking me that?” Monoma cut his eyes at him. He didn’t slow his stride as they walked down the busy hallway of men and women in black and white suits. “You know we’re not supposed to discuss that with each other. Folders are *classified*.”

“Don’t act so uptight all the time,” Katsuki said coolly. “C’mon, I’m curious. I’m sure you’re curious as to who I got too.”

Monoma pursed his lips. Katsuki had to resist smiling because he knew exactly what to say to get Monoma’s nosy ass on board with anything he said. The other young blond looked over their shoulder and then jutted his head in the direction somewhere more discreet. They both walked over to a less active part of The Company where people who slacked off went. Currently, it was just them two. Both of them opened their folders on the count of three, smiling like it was an innocent game.

However, the smile on Katsuki’s face was wiped off when he saw the picture inside of Monoma’s folder.

It was Imasuji Goto.

Katsuki furrowed his brow. He cut his eye at Monoma who was studying his facial expression carefully. They both grew quiet and Katsuki straightened out his back.

“Ah. You *do* know him,” Monoma pointed out. “I thought so. You two look nearly identical. Is this a family member of yours or something?”

Katsuki didn't answer that.

He prodded his tongue in the side of his cheek, unhappy.

He wondered if it was just a stroke of luck. Aizawa didn't know about the connection between him and Imasuji Goto as far as he knew. But the fact the man had a hit on him was curious. It was even more curious how it somehow didn't land in his hands.

As Katsuki stared at the picture in the red folder, he could hear his mother's words rattle loud in his head. The degenerate side of him started recounting his mother's story to him so loud it drowned out all his rational thoughts. All he could picture was Imasuji Goto dead on the floor. Covered in vibrant, scarlet blood.

A person with a rap like Muscular didn't merit a swift, tranquil death. No, that was too easy.

"Switch folders with me," Katsuki demanded suddenly.

"*Excuse me*?" Monoma exclaimed. He recoiled like Katsuki had bit him. "Are you *insane*? I already let you look at the folder. I'm not switching with you. Are you trying to get us fired?"

"I'll give you half of the payment I'm going to receive."

Monoma stiffened at the offer. He stole a glance at the red folder in his hand and then back at Katsuki. Another emotion slowly crept in Monoma's face. Judgmental and stale. Like a switch, he straightened out his back and tilted his head and his eyes became stone cold.

"First you tell me what he is to you," Monoma said. "Then I'll *consider* it."

Katsuki clenched his jaw, picking his words carefully.

"He's my biological father." This was the first time Katsuki said it out loud and it felt wrong. "I want to be the one to do it, he's hurt my mother in the past. He's scum so I'm sure you understand a painless bullet isn't what he deserves."

His colleague didn't say anything further and he didn't have to. The judgment flowing out of Monoma's eyes was all that needed to be exchanged. Disbelief, slight repulsion and also curiosity translated from blue eyes to red.

Monoma gave him the folder. He handed it to him like it was a test. Katsuki gripped on tight to the folder and his demons ferociously smirked with all their sharp teeth.

"Have fun," Monoma said with a sinister smile.

Monsters recognized monsters.

☽ ☽ ☽

"In shocking news, the death of one of the most notorious crime lords in Japan has occurred," the news anchor said with a gripping voice. "Imasuji Goto's body was found this morning in an abandoned warehouse. All over the scene was his blood, like he had been purposefully

drained. And his body sustained multiple bullet wounds, stab wounds and mutilations I can't say on public television."

Her eyes were shocked, amazed and terrified all at once. Beside her on the screen flashed blurry images of Imasuji Goto's butchered body. He had been maimed beyond recognition in the dead of night then crucified with rusty nails to the walls in the same warehouse where he committed most of his crimes.

Above him in blood was painted the words *'Filth'*.

Then finally the news showed one last photo: a very blurry shot of Katsuki in the dark. He was dressed in all black with blood stains across the small sliver of his eyes.

In the deep darkness, his blazing illuminating red eyes were the only thing visible.

"The public has nicknamed this murderer the Scarlet Eyed Killer. News of the incident has swept the nation and has been deemed one of the most brutal murders of the century—"

Aizawa angrily clicked off the television in his office.

Katsuki dared at that moment to look to his right. Sitting next to him was Monoma, head down in shame with him. They both were sporting vicious red marks on their cheek from the earlier events. When the news broke, Aizawa had come storming out of his office radiating nothing but pure fucking rage. Their supervisor slapped them both with all his strength, stunning everyone and then dragged them into his office none too kindly.

Now they were here, and The Scarlet Eyed killer was the most talked about thing on all news channels.

But what was worse, the blurry image of his deadly eyes was circulating like poison in the body.

"I cannot fucking *believe* you two," Aizawa snapped. His face was twisted in disgust, and he was downright livid. The veins in his neck and forehead were popping forward as he grinded his teeth. "What the hell is wrong with you two? *Hah*!? If I give out an assignment to one of you it is against direct fucking orders to switch! You both know this!"

Katsuki had never heard Aizawa's voice boom so loudly. It rivaled roaring thunder, quaking through him like an avalanche. Katsuki was stunned into silence, because he hadn't thought about the consequences of what they had done.

"Fucking say something you two dumbasses or I'm firing both of you," Aizawa yelled. "Contracts be fucking damned I will let you both *starve for this*. I do not tolerate this kind of shit on my watch."

"I'm sorry," Monoma whispered first. His fists were shaking. "But it's not *my* fault. I didn't know Bakugou would go off the rails like that—"

"—*I knew*!" Aizawa cut him off with an unnerving boom. He marched up to both of them looming like a storm cloud. "It's not your goddamn job to know, it's *mine*. This is why I give

you very specific assignments. I don't give them out fucking randomly. I knew Bakugou would act like a goddamn psychopath and that's why I *didn't* give him that assignment! It was too close to his goddamn emotions and not well enough removed from his logic!"

Monoma frowned like he disagreed but didn't say anything. He cut his eyes angrily at Katsuki to speak up, but Katsuki stayed silent.

Aizawa cut his eyes too and his nostrils flared when he saw Katsuki hanging his head away.

"And *you*," Aizawa nearly growled in a low voice. The tiny red veins in his eyes were deeper in color than usual and his gaze pulsed with disdain. "What you did was *disgusting*."

Katsuki worked his jaw.

He should be feeling regret right now, but he really fucking didn't.

His stinging cheek from where he had been slapped was throbbing and probably was as red as Aizawa's face. But he didn't give a single fuck. Katsuki cut his eyes up to Aizawa in a silent challenge without saying a word. The two stared at each other, frowning in distaste for the other without words being changed.

Without taking his sights off Katsuki, Aizawa said very carefully, "Monoma. Get the hell out of my office. I don't want to see your face for the rest of the week."

Monoma didn't need to be told twice. He sprung up from the chair and rushed out of the door. He shut it behind him.

Aizawa's livid expression didn't waiver a single bit. "Do you even regret what you did?"

"Why would I regret it?" Katsuki quipped.

"You *butchered* him," Aizawa emphasized. "You nearly put this fucking company at risk after I fucking told you that this assignment needed to be discreet. Now a photograph of your goddamn eyes is circulating all over Japan and probably halfway across the world. You fucked up all because you let your goddamn emotions get the best of you! What did I tell you about acting from a place of calm and not fucking *passion*—"

"—He deserved it," Katsuki retorted. "I don't regret it and I'm *never* going to regret killing that bastard the way I did because it felt *good*."

Aizawa searched his face like he was viewing him for the first time.

He stepped back, offset by what Katsuki had said. Aizawa let out a long, shaky sigh and pinched the bridge of his nose. He turned away from Katsuki finally and stared at the wall as if searching for an answer.

"I'm so disappointed in you," Aizawa whispered tiredly.

The words were soft, had no bite and were barely audible. But no matter how delicate they were, they pierced through Katsuki like daggers. Katsuki didn't anticipate that at all, it was

sobering to look at Aizawa shunning him.

His heart stopped hammering and feelings of conflict rattled in his chest.

Disappointed?

“You’re off all red folder assignments until further notice,” Aizawa muttered. “I’m not trying to enable serial killer habits, Bakugou. I’m trying to train effective hitmen who will understand that using their goddamn head is more important than a family grudge.”

Aizawa kept his back towards him, and Katsuki painfully wanted him to actually turn around. He wanted him to look at him like he was fucking proud because what he did was good. Right? It was fucking needed—

“Get out of my office,” Aizawa muttered.

Katsuki lifted up from his place in the chair slowly. All his feelings of rage were dismantled now, washed away with that simple word. Disappointed. He stared at Aizawa’s stiff back and the way he was hunched over his desk like he had failed at something miserably. Katsuki stayed stuck for a while, feet unmoving. He walked up carefully to his supervisor, reaching out a hand. But the moment he was about to touch Aizawa’s back the man snapped at him.

“I said get the fuck out of my office, Bakugou. I don’t want to see you.”

Katsuki retracted his hand like he had been stung. The hurt in Aizawa’s voice pained him more than his throbbing cheek. Katsuki wearily glanced around at all the pictures on the wall of him. This was the first time he had really looked at them, but he saw pictures of Sero, Denki, Monoma, Shinsou and him scattered around. They were hung up and placed above any photos with politicians Aizawa had on the wall.

He looked at the photo of Koji on Aizawa’s desk.

Katsuki huffed angrily, upset with not understanding Aizawa or his emotions.

He stormed out of the office in a blur.

As Katsuki passed by in the office halls, everyone kept referring to him as one thing. The whispers were loud, taunting and they stabbed tiny holes in his skin, deflating his ego. They kept repeating the same thing over and over: *he’s a real murderer*. They all looked at him differently—like he wasn’t one of *them*. The mutters were loud and Katsuki heard every single sentence.

He had been branded a monster and no one would view him any differently now.

The Scarlet Eyed Killer had left his mark.

Chapter End Notes

Let me know what you think below! 💜

Big thank you to Minty who told me about the goose virus and Monet who nicknamed the Migraine Unit 🤣💕

Sorry for catching up on comments so late. I am feeling much better now after some rest and finally getting around to replying to the Ch. 10 comments ^^ I will be replying to them steadily because I really do appreciate you all! All the comments you leave I read every single one and smile. It makes me really happy that we have one more interlude chapter, which will be a lot of the final pieces to the puzzle.

Every chapter as like a very specific domino needed for the progression of the climax and I'm sooooo excited we reached like midway in this story. It feels surreal finally arrive here after day dreaming about this fic for about a year :)

Thanks so much for reading ^^ 💚💚💚

Chapter 13: Interlude IV

Chapter Summary

Katsuki gets the keys to his mother's home.

Chapter Notes

Hello!! Welcome back to the last interlude :) it's a fun one! It ends on a sad note, so be mindful of your state of mind while going into this. All tags apply (minus knife play, that's later)

Big thanks to Luna, the love of my life, for betaing!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 13 — Interlude IV

.

.

.

After the news of the Scarlet Eyed Killer spread through Japan, everyone started to look at Katsuki differently.

The people at The Company parted ways for him, as if afraid of his touch. Aizawa took time to rebound to treat him the same ever again. His team members on the M-Unit started to tilt their heads at him a bit, all save the exception of Monoma and Shinsou. They seemed to understand him. They felt like the blood he spilled was rightfully reaped.

But most surprising, was how his mother looked at him.

He remembers how her face was shocked, yet blank watching the news of Muscular's murder. She wasn't stupid either, she knew. There was a look of knowing when the blurry photograph of his blood lust eyes flashed on the screen.

She had turned her head to him and spoke. "Katsuki. Was that you?"

Katsuki didn't see a point in lying. "It was."

She nodded, as if in approval. She continued to do what she was doing and after that, she was kinder to him. She called him more, she seemed more upbeat. She started exchanging more stories about how she met his father when she was pregnant. It seemed like a weight off her chest had been lifted by seeing that news story.

Ultimately, his mother gave him the approval for the blood he shed unlike Aizawa. And that made the dark part of Katsuki feel validated. In contrast to his mother, Aizawa stayed true to his word. His boss kept him on strictly green folder missions with no goddamn leeway.

Katsuki wouldn't usually give a damn, *but* it seemed like with green folders came a certain green haired pest. Deku. Of course, who the hell else would it be? It was beginning to drive Katsuki up the goddamn *wall*.

He first encountered Deku again at some random high-end hotel. Katsuki had been guarding his mark, some wealthy bastard with too many gold rings Katsuki didn't care too much for. After that, Katsuki quickly started to see a pattern that Deku was good at blending in to get closer to the mark to kill them.

The wealthy bastard had been horny after his business deal, and he was being picky about who he wanted to fuck. He mentioned to Katsuki that he found some cute man with a bubble butt that he was going to take to his chambers and ravish. Katsuki held in his eye roll about it and decided to go along with the assignment.

However, when he walked the man into his suite, there was Deku in *another* goddamn wig waiting for him in barely any clothes. The other assassin was posing as some minx trying to seduce the mark so he could slit his throat in bed probably.

Like Taiwan, when Katsuki and Deku locked eyes, uncontrollable wrath was unleashed. It wound up with another shoot out that resulted in Katsuki having a bloody gunshot wound. Deku, fucking Deku, put a goddamn bullet in his *foot* then escaped out of the window. The smaller assassin swiftly jumped out of the window in a blur of green and landed on a lower balcony, far out of Katsuki's reach. Deku successfully made his escape but not before glaring at Katsuki from the lower level. The little bastard gave him the finger.

The next few assignments after that didn't have Deku. But as the year progressed, he saw Deku every couple of months.

He saw Deku at the shady night clubs.

He saw Deku at the fancy banquet halls.

He saw Deku during the dead of night as drug lords exchanged contraband.

It was beginning to be exhausting. How the fuck did one tiny man work his ass all around Japan? Every assignment ended the same and it was beginning to be an inside joke amongst his unit. Denki thought it would be funny to leave little broccolis all over his desk and Monoma would always be sure to tell him good luck every time he got a green folder with a shit eating smirk.

Katsuki was able to always stop Deku from killing his mark. Which was starting to result in Deku's actions becoming slightly desperate.

Then one mission, something particular happened.

The green folder Katsuki received, it was a pretty heavily detailed assignment.

His mark this time was an elder man who was the most tranquil person he ever met. His name was Soto Genkei and he had a syrupy warm smile. His fair skin was wrinkled with wisdom and his hair was streaked with white and silver. He spent most of his days baking and making dango for his guests and family. He was probably one of the kindest people Katsuki ever met in person.

However, while Genkai was a peaceful man currently, his past was bloodier than Katsuki's.

The man used to be known as the Midnight Butcher in Tokyo in his prime.

Before forensics were really a thing, he spent a lot of his youth killing for men and women far more powerful than him. He did it with a butcher ax and he did it with glee. Sometimes he even did it unprovoked on unsuspecting civilians to 'practice' his art form. After he gained so much money, he decided to retire, but one doesn't get involved in sticky business like theirs without *some* grudge being formed.

Genkei received an anonymous letter spelled with magazine cut outs in the mail one day. Underneath the words 'Midnight butcher' were old, black and white photographs of his victims and in sloppy lettering 'retribution will come' at the bottom.

Genkei was scared his past would catch him because he had a family now. A wife, three kids and a granddaughter and grandson. He wished to live happily and swore that he atoned for his past crimes. Viewing him now, Katsuki could argue that to be true. The Genkei in front of him wouldn't harm a fly, but seeing that letter spoke to the side of Katsuki that believed in vengeance. This man used to kill for *practice*. No grayness about it.

Over dinner that night in the man's house, Katsuki couldn't help but pose a question once everyone else had gone to bed.

"Why did you do all those murders?" Katsuki asked. He looked at the ripples in his tea in the porcelain cup carefully. "With an ax nonetheless."

"I was paid," Genkei said with a tranquil smile.

Katsuki shook his head. "No. I mean the ones for practice, the twenty people you had killed who didn't have to die."

Genkei froze. His eyes softened with wisdom beyond Katsuki's years. Wrinkled hands smoothed over the fabric of his yukata. "I couldn't tell you what the inner workings of my past self is like. I can only advocate for the one that is sitting in front of you, and I am a changed man."

"You murdered over twenty people, and you can't tell me?" Katsuki questioned, unsure.

The corners of Genkei's mouth tugged down slightly. His peace-loving aura tainted with defensiveness and his grip on the teapot grew so tight a small crack could be heard.

"I can't," Genkei muttered.

Their eyes locked in a strange challenge and plea. Katsuki tilted his head at him. Then from down the hall Genkei's grandson called his name. The elder man rose from the floor and gave Katsuki a tight smile.

"Have a good rest of your night," Genkei said with a bow. "The guest room is ready for you. I will let you know when you may leave until it feels like I am safe."

Katsuki didn't continue the conversation further. He went to the guest room in his pajamas and looked at the black and white photos of the victims. He researched on his phone all of the twenty victims and read their stories. Many had families still looking for the murderer, and others had given up.

Later that night, of course, there was an intruder.

Katsuki had been the only person to hear the picking of the lock on the window in the house. He sprung forward from the sleeping mat and grabbed for his gun. He loaded it up and crept quietly. He followed his plan and locked the bedroom doors on all of Genkei and his family members so whoever couldn't kill them. When Katsuki poised himself around the corner, he could hear someone tip toeing forward.

When the person turned the corner, vibrant viridian eyes shone in the moonlit hallway, and they locked eyes with their guns pointed at each other.

The first thing Katsuki noticed was the black eye.

The second thing he noticed was the foreign despair in Deku's eyes. The mystery assassin was quiet, and he didn't pull his trigger right away like all the other times. He looked—hurt. Really fucking hurt, and his eyes were blood shot mimicking fire with how dark and inflamed they were.

What happened that night Katsuki never told anyone.

An odd plea on Deku's face triggered something inside of Katsuki. Tumbling forward, all the victim's grainy photographs flashed through his mind. He saw their smiles, their frowns, and recalled their families and their stories. They were so painfully real to him in that moment, like shadows looming behind him. He could feel twenty ghost hands on top of his own that were pushing down.

Katsuki lowered his gun under the weight of the phantom limbs and Deku relaxed in shock.

Katsuki pursed his lips and looked down to the ground. He quietly walked over to Genkei's bedroom where he was sleeping and unlocked it.

Katsuki turned his back and Deku never pulled the trigger.

Deku walked into that room and quietly did something to Genkei. Katsuki didn't know what he did, but there was no knife or gunshot. Genkei stopped breathing and his face turned blue. Then slowly Deku walked out of the house, but not before looking over his shoulder at Katsuki.

"Thank you," Deku whispered quietly.

Before he got the chance to reply, Deku disappeared into the night.

Katsuki went to bed in the guest room and closed his eyes. When he woke up the next morning, Genkei's family was distraught and crying.

The medical examiners came and determined it was a heart attack in his sleep. Katsuki insisted that the family get a refund since it was a 'natural' tragedy and Aizawa didn't really question it. He gave the money back and it was enough to cover the funeral expenses. Katsuki thought he might feel worse about it, but he didn't.

He felt like it was justified as he thought about all the innocent faces on that letter.

☽ ☽ ☽

When Katsuki was nineteen he started to notice the other people in The Company pairing off.

He had never, er, given romance another thought after Tokyo and the cringe issue of his pretend marriage. Besides, when would he between all the shit he had to take care of? He didn't understand that and last time he attempted to flirt with someone, it ended up being shitty ass Deku. *Twice*.

But he was reluctantly curious about dating at this age when he could see his unit start to indulge in these things.

Denki started having pretty casual sex with men and women. Shinsou very much made it clear he was not interested in romance or sex. Katsuki considered maybe he was like Shinsou, but after examining himself closely, he realized he wasn't. Then there was Sero, who was secretly pining for Denki. Katsuki could've shot Sero for the number of times he sobbed whenever Denki went home with someone.

But the most confusing one was Monoma.

He always knew Monoma had a girlfriend, but when they met her he didn't understand how the *fuck* did it work with his colleague's shitty personality. Her name was Kendo Itsuka, and she loved Monoma more than Katsuki could really understand. She was bubbly, pretty, and had a soft shade of ginger hair.

It didn't make any damn sense. He thought for sure this was some type of fake dating shit. But when they all went out as a group to karaoke, Katsuki watched the pair of them closely.

They were in love, and it twisted terrible curiosity at the bottom of Katsuki's core to see that up close after so long. The lonely part of him yearned for that type of affection. Hand

touching. Smiling. Even with Monoma's shitty ass singing she looked at him as if he was giving a serenade.

Katsuki had never experienced that before.

Hell, when was the last time he even had a *hug*?

He thought of the boy from Tokyo and wished his face wasn't blurry.

☽ ☽ ☽

Thoughts of dating were on the forefront of Katsuki's mind after seeing Monoma and Itsuka together.

Currently, he was nervously tapping his foot in his mother's apartment. He was thinking about stupid romance more than he would like. Several questions were booming in his head: if he dated someone how would they look? Act? Speak? Would he prefer men or women? The answer to that last one came unfortunately easy when he thought of a certain green haired assassin.

"What's on your mind?" Mitsuki asked while making dinner. She chopped the carrot in her hand with sharp precision and smiled at him across the kitchen island. "You look like you're a little bit stressed. Hard day at work?"

"I think I'm gay," Katsuki blurted out.

Mitsuki stopped chopping. Katsuki pursed his lips and fiddled with his fingers.

"Oh," Mitsuki said. She blinked a couple of times like she never anticipated having this conversation. Then she nodded and smiled brightly. "That's good! I'm happy for you."

Katsuki was a little hesitant. He looked at her carefully and how relaxed she seemed. "You're alright with it?"

"Of course, why wouldn't I be, brat? I'm your mother," Mitsuki said with a soft smile. She leaned over and pinched his cheek lovingly. "I'm *always* going to support you no matter what you do. Especially after everything we've been through, Katsuki. But this is a bit random. Did you see some cute guy you liked?"

Katsuki willed away the image of fucking freckles that appeared in his head.

"No. I don't have anyone in mind," he forcefully said. "I was just giving it some thought. Some of my friends are dating."

"Do you want to date too?" She started chopping the carrot again and Katsuki was surprised how simple that was.

"Maybe?" Katsuki glanced around and his eye landed on an overdue bill. A hint of sourness twisted his stomach at the sight. He pretended like he didn't see it. "But I'm not sure. I don't know if I'll have the time."

“Nonsense!” Mitsuki exclaimed loudly. She clasped her hands together and pointed at him with the knife. “You’re a handsome young man and you got *my* damn good looks. I see the way people check you out when we’re in public. Frankly, I thought you just didn’t like anyone enough to date but if that’s what you want, we can get you started.”

Katsuki tilted his head. “Started? How?”

“I can introduce you to my coworker’s son,” Mitsuki suggested. “I’m pretty sure my coworker mentioned her son being bisexual. He’s a nice boy and he’s studying to be a lawyer.”

“I don’t know if I want to mingle with anyone you work with considering…” He let the sentence trail off and his mother took the hint. She nodded and took a deep breath.

“…Right,” Mitsuki muttered. “Okay. There’s other ways. Some of my coworkers mentioned this thing called tender? Timber? I’m not sure but it’s an app for dating. That’s what people your age mainly use, right?”

“I don’t know.”

“How do you not know? You’re nineteen.”

“I don’t *know*. I never gave this stuff any thought, alright? Cut me some damn slack.”

“Okay, if you want, we can do this the old way and you go out and find someone. That’s how I met your father. Oh! That can be really fun. I can set you up looking cool and suave in a bookstore! Or the grocery market. I see a lot of handsome young men at the local market down the street.”

“…Let’s try the app thing,” Katsuki muttered.

He shied away from her a bit when he suddenly realized maybe this was too much for him to grasp. He was good at his job. He was good at being financially responsible. He could pay bills and slit throats—but this? He didn’t quite know how to be datable or if he was even likable.

“Tember it is!” Mitsuki exclaimed excitedly.

She seemed extremely giddy and delighted as she started looking up dating apps on her phone. She came across several and over dinner the two of them watched YouTube videos on ‘how to make the perfect dating profile’ together.

His mom gave her own input and advice on how to compliment people, how to make eye contact and how to always make sure he made the person he was dating feel special. She pulled this all from her experience with his father and it made Katsuki smile softly to himself. When they finished dinner Mitsuki and Katsuki dressed him up in his best clothes and took pictures for his profile.

They sat on the bed and crafted his bio and Katsuki for the first time really felt normal.

☽ ☽ ☽

Over the next week, he had swiped and fucking swiped endlessly.

Absolutely *no one* fit into his tastes for a partner. It was annoying. This guy liked playing the fiddle. This other one wasn't looking for anything serious. Another said his favorite goddamn color was periwinkle—how goddamn pretentious.

"You're being way too damn harsh," Mitsuki pointed out. She lit the cigarette in her mouth and shook her head at him. "Cast a wider net and I'm sure you'll find someone. Don't be such a picky brat."

"Fine," Katsuki grumbled and swiped left three more times. "I'll try to be less *picky*."

But the truth was, he couldn't.

Every time his eyes landed on some guy he kept seeing goddamn *Deku*. He had been so ready to ask Deku out—fucking *twice*. What was it about those instances that were so far different then now? Deku, despite being fucking annoying, he learned really was his type. Doll face, sweet looking, cute freckles and he had a gentle voice. In another lifetime, he could find himself on a date with Deku had he not tried to kill him on several occasions now.

At the end of the week, he did as his mother asked. He started swiping right a bit more graciously and began going on dates.

And it was fucking awful. He had jack shit in common with anyone and the worst part is he felt like people could see through him. Katsuki internally cringed when he could see the various men withdraw away from him when his answers to their valid questions were subpar.

"So, what do you like to do for fun?" One guy he thought he liked asked over dinner.

"I sometimes like to listen to classical music," Katsuki said.

"Oh! Neat. Anything else?"

"No."

A grimace.

All the rest of the dates went like this too and it was beginning to chip away at Katsuki's ego. He apparently had the looks to get him through the door but absolutely nothing else to make people stay.

Next he tried hitting on guys at The Company. He would be discreet and attempt to flirt but everyone would give him weary smiles and shuffle away. He didn't fucking get it. What was the problem? Did his breath fucking stink? Everyone else at The Company was pairing off and running around with a goddamn relationship. They were all getting lo—*affection*. Why couldn't he?

Those cruel whispers from his childhood came back to him, full force.

“The problem is you,” his self doubt murmured. “You’re just not a good enough person for anyone to like.”

“Even if someone did like you they’re going to leave you,” his anxiety muttered. “One day you’ll wake up and be by yourself again.”

“You’re unlovable,” his self-hatred stated cruelly. “Who could ever love a monster like you?”

These whispers grew louder and louder every single failed date.

After about two months in a lull of assignments, Katsuki had to put all his inquiring about dating on pause. Aizawa called with another assignment for him. Katsuki was slightly relieved because he was beginning to spiral.

However, when he arrived at The Company, waiting for him in the common area were his friends and they were all laughing on their phones.

Katsuki walked in, ready to go about his day, but frowned when his four teammates were laughing and looking at him a little too hard.

He scowled and turned around. “What’s so damn funny?”

“I don’t know,” Monoma said pleasantly. “Why don’t you tell us, Bakugou Katsuki who likes classical music and long walks on the beach. Since when did you ever walk on the beach? We don’t even live near one.”

Monoma turned to him with a shit eating annoying smirk and lifted up his phone. Sitting there on the screen was a photograph of Katsuki in his ripped jeans, leather jacket and all black attire winking at the screen. Denki and Sero burst out in laughter and everyone in the vicinity started staring at them.

Embarrassment raced hot in Katsuki until the tips of his ears burned red. “Wh—How the hell did you find my fucking profile?!”

“Dude, I use Tinder too,” Denki explained with a grin. “Imagine my surprise when your grouchy face popped up on my screen with these dorky photos. It looks like your mom took these for you.”

Katsuki fumed quietly and his face grew redder.

Shinsou raised an eyebrow at Katsuki’s silence. “…Did she?”

“And what if she did?” Katsuki bit out, hiding his blush.

“Oh my fucking *god*,” Sero howled. He doubled over holding his stomach. “She did! This is rich!”

“Fuck off, all of you,” Katsuki hissed. “I can date around if I want to.”

Monoma smirked at him. “Have you found anyone you like?”

“No,” Katsuki grumbled. “Everyone I meet just wants to try to get into my pants. Which I guess is a compliment, but no one wants to go on a second date or go further.”

“Basically, you’re having trouble making them stick?” Shinsou clarified.

“…Yeah,” Katsuki resentfully admitted. He glanced down at his boots, sourly recalling the 15th failed date he had gone on. The cute guy said he would call back but instead he fucking ghosted him. “I don’t know what the hell I’m doing wrong. I’m hot, right? I should be already fucking cozied up with a cute boyfriend by now.”

“It’s probably because your personality is shit,” Monoma said bluntly. Katsuki stiffened and cut his eye up at his colleague. “You really think someone is going to want to *seriously* date you with how brash you are? Any sane person would run for the hills.”

“I would pay to be a fly on the wall for one of your dates, man,” Sero laughed. “I bet Bakugou thinks flirting is insulting someone.”

“I can see it now, he definitely told someone they didn’t look *awful*.” Denki chuckled.

His friends laughed and jeered at him a bit more. It was all in humor and good fun, but it fucked with a specific part of Katsuki.

Those looming whispers in the back of his head were getting loud with each joke made at his expense. The dark spirit inside of him wasn’t smiling, it was weeping and begging to see if what was said was true. He could be loved. He could be. He repeated this thought until the unrelenting whispers quieted down.

When the conversation in the group shifted off of him, Katsuki zoned out. He sat in the common area for Aizawa to come get him with a distant stare.

Then out of the corner of his eye someone caught his attention with a small wave.

Katsuki turned at the gesture, and he recognized the person as another worker at The Company. He was a cute guy with curly, black hair and an athletic build. He was muscular in all the right places Katsuki liked and he had a sweet smile. He had seen the guy around a couple of times, he was one of the people that would bite his lip at Katsuki when he would walk by. They had exchanged a couple of words and he knew he was about their age, but he never really knew who he was.

Katsuki wondered how much of that conversation the other teen heard when a wink was sent his way.

☽ ☽ ☽

Quickly, Katsuki found out the mystery teen’s name was Mako.

Mako was in a different sector and took a lot of red assignments. The cute guy seemed to like him a lot, or at least Katsuki *thought* he did.

The other teen made a very blunt pass at Katsuki after the common area, and Katsuki in all his terrible curiosity decided to roll with it. This was the closest to real damn intimacy he ever had with someone.

Over the course of six months, they got to know each other well. At the first week mark, after what Katsuki thought were dates, they slept together and he found out he did in fact, like sex a *whole* fucking lot. Especially when he fucked Mako from the back, choking him in the dark. The other teen's deep colored curls bounced enchantingly as he gasped for air. That alone fed Katsuki a *very* specific image he would never say out loud.

Mako often commented on how rough he was—which Katsuki didn't exactly understand because he was just doing what felt good. He tried to fuck Mako softer but found out he wasn't sure he knew how. His thrusts were always choppy and off beat and his kisses were awkward when he attempted to mimic what the fuck being 'soft' was.

Mako would roll his eyes and tell him it was alright. The other teen gave up and instructed Katsuki to do what felt right. So, Katsuki did. He could do rough. He could do hard. He could choke and fuck and make Mako cum hard enough to see stars.

Katsuki was positive that this arrangement would eventually end with them being steady. They worked together. They slept together. Hell, Mako even came over to his apartment to stay the night sometimes. It was the perfect damn set up.

Then the rug was pulled from under him one day while making out in the back of Mako's luxury car.

They were devouring each other, smirking into kisses and Katsuki was a single item of clothing away from being nude. He looked down at Mako under him, blushing deeply and spread out like a good boy as he pumped his cock in his hand. As Mako expertly stroked him, Katsuki groaned deeply. He ran his thumb along Mako's plump lip in deep thought.

"Hey," Katsuki rasped out. "Would you ever want to get serious with me?"

"Wh-What?" Mako stopped his movements. His pretty purple eyes went wide, and he visibly recoiled. "Where is this coming from?"

Katsuki immediately sensed that apparently that was the wrong thing to say. Mako was looking at him like he had gone mad and it worried Katsuki. Katsuki cleared his throat and ran his hand through Mako's hair gently.

"Hypothetically of course," Katsuki covered up. "Do you think I'm…serious boyfriend material? I'm curious."

Mako began blinking and quickly sucked in his lips to suppress a tiny snicker.

The corners of Katsuki's mouth tugged down. "Why are you laughing?"

"I'm sorry but I didn't think you would be the type to *want* a relationship," Mako said nonchalantly. "We've been fucking for what? Six months? I thought you weren't like that at

all. It's kind of why I…went after you."

Katsuki frowned harder and retracted his hand from Mako. "Huh?"

"You're The Scarlet Eyed Killer," Mako said like it was obvious. "You're very handsome and rough in bed, but, um, those aren't exactly boyfriend or *husband* qualities. After what happened on the news, I know there's a couple people who are very much avoiding you…it's why no one at work wants to date you."

Katsuki's face slowly fell.

People were afraid of him.

Suddenly all the avoidance at work and the stares were no longer passive. They cut deep into him, and he could feel the judgment crawling up and down his skin like vicious hawk eyes.

"Hey. I didn't mean that in a bad way," Mako spoke softly. "I meant it in a good way. You're, *Bakugou*. You carry yourself like you don't have feelings or care about that type of stuff. I thought you wouldn't ever want a relationship. I didn't *actually* hurt your feelings, did I?"

"What feelings?" Katsuki said bitterly. He shoved down all his emotions and pressed his lips in a thin line. "I was just asking a dumb question. Of course, I don't want to date seriously, it would just get in the way of what I'm best at."

"Fucking?" Mako said half-heartedly with humor. Katsuki didn't laugh. The other teen shifted awkwardly under Katsuki and patted his cheek with false affection. "C'mon, no more silly questions. Let's get back to having fun like we've been having."

Katsuki resisted scowling as the tornado inside of him swirled until he felt beyond angry. His fury twisted into uncontrollable hurt and then those whispers in the back of his head sneered, *"I told you so."*

Katsuki fucked Mako that night out of pure spite and never spoke to the other teen again.

☽ ☽ ☽

By the time Katsuki was twenty, he accepted he was not crafted for love.

He hardened his shell to the point he never thought of romance ever again—and it was fucking fantastic. He woke up every morning knowing he only had to take care of two people in this world: him and his mother.

That was enough for him, and he silenced that tiny voice in his head that yammered about useless crap. It kept trying to speak to him and whispered that he wasn't worthy of love or whatever bullshit that was. Katsuki decided to give it no more power.

If he wasn't good enough to be loved then fine. He didn't want it.

Katsuki was comfortable with sex and moving on with his life after getting his fill. Or at least that's what he told himself.

His days were routine: hanging out with his friends, going to work and listening to Denki rant about his rock collection. Find the latest fuck which was easy with his looks and go no further with anyone. His heart stung deeply when he saw couples at The Company, and all he wanted to do was shove in their face how fucking meaningless their romance was.

After he got off of work, he would go to the small flower shop on the way to his mother's apartment and pick up a bundle of pink carnations. She would smile and tell him how much of an amazing son he was. Katsuki grinned every time this happened.

Despite everything failing on the romance front when he was nineteen, his mom was finally better and that's all he could ask for. The last year with her had been perfect, and he felt like he finally had the mother he wanted as a child the last two years.

Then the first domino in a long string of events was set off without his knowledge.

Aizawa had called up M-Unit to his office this one particular Tuesday. He didn't give too many details, just a curt text that read: "Have a big assignment. Let's all discuss it at 07:00."

None of them questioned it, Aizawa was always cryptic. When 07:00 rolled around, it was bright and early and for some damn reason—Aizawa's office was locked. Shinsou thought this was curious and jiggled the handle a bit and then Katsuki pressed his ear to the door.

He could pick up on the muffled sounds of voices coming from inside. Eventually 07:00 turned to 07:42 which transformed into 08:25. They had been waiting for fucking *ever*. Ultimately they all took a seat outside of Aizawa's office until that damned door opened.

Katsuki was bored out of his mind as he played some dumb games on his phone. Monoma and Shinsou were quietly sitting next to him on the couch. They were discussing something random like the news and missing children. On the other side of the tiny space, Sero was poorly flirting with the obvious dunce head Denki. The sight made Katsuki's lip curl in disgust because that was a match he did *not* see coming. Hell, Denki didn't even see it to be fair.

When Katsuki's watch read 09:02, the door to Aizawa's office creaked open.

Katsuki usually paid no mind to the type of people that walked out of his supervisor's office. But this instance was different when he was hit with the smell of sharp, rich cologne. It gripped his senses and pulled his eyes up to the party of men exiting out of Aizawa's office.

It was a group of seven, tall men. Six had disease masks and jet-black hair. The only one who didn't was in the center and Katsuki didn't need to ask if he was the leader.

He was a tall man with reddish brown hair and eyes as gold as all the riches in the world. He carried himself like he was a descendant of a family worthwhile, with a sharp regal air coating him. He was dressed in an all-black suit with delicate golden trimming and his coat that had black, fur lining around the collar. He reminded Katsuki of a crow with how sharp the edges of his eyes were.

Aizawa walked behind the group with his head down. Katsuki frowned at that sight. Aizawa rarely held his head down. But this was different. There was a specific, disquieted aura coating Aizawa. Katsuki caught his supervisor's eye and the elder man gestured for him to turn his head away.

But it was too late when the crow-like man turned his golden gaze on Katsuki.

The feeling of crawling serpents under his skin ignited. The eerie feeling slithered up the hills of his spine and settled at the base of his neck with a chill.

"You look familiar," The crow-like man said carefully. His words were concise and carefully chosen. All the flare guns shot off in Katsuki's head at the way golden eyes pierced into him. "…Extremely familiar actually."

Katsuki didn't exactly know what to say. His intuition was telling him to run, but he couldn't. Instead, all he could do was work his jaw as he fought against his instincts towards danger. He sucked his breath in when he realized that statement could mean a number of things. That could be related to his resemblance with Muscular. A very dangerous crime lord with endless connections—or that could also be related to the fact his eyes were circulating all over the news right now.

Both of which meant trouble.

"What's your name?" The man asked curiously.

"My apologies, Mr. Chisaki," Aizawa quickly cut in. He stepped forward swiftly and plastered his face with a tight, polite smile. "I'm afraid names are strictly off limits here. I don't allow for my men's identity to be revealed unless they want them to."

"But you didn't ask if he wanted to," the man now identified as Mr. Chisaki replied in a heartbeat. He looked Katsuki up and down carefully. "Do you want to tell me your name?"

"Um," Katsuki stumbled on his words, unsure what the fuck was happening. He darted his eyes between Aizawa and the strange man. Something was off. Aizawa gave a discreet shake of the head and that was all Katsuki needed. "No, sorry. I prefer my identity to be concealed."

Mr. Chisaki cut his sharp eyes to Aizawa. He raised a thin eyebrow carefully rather than responding. It was anomalous and Katsuki struggled to read Chisaki's emotions. Chisaki's features were utterly too perfect, impeccable even. He was hiding something malicious underneath his guise of civility.

Then in a split second, the cold demeanor thawed, and Mr. Chisaki bowed politely to Katsuki.

"My apologies," Mr. Chisaki said humbly. "You remind me of an old friend I haven't seen in a while." He then turned to Aizawa and bowed. "I will be keeping in touch about any future assignments I may need handled. I appreciate you setting aside the time today to talk."

"It's an honor. It's a pleasure doing business with you, Mr. Chisaki," Aizawa said.

The group of stale faced men began to exit, but not before Mr. Chisaki set his golden gaze on Katsuki one last time. There was an underlying notion in that gesture Katsuki never understood. It was odd, and a little too personal. Like he was looking straight through him.

When the men were gone and out of ear shot, Aizawa released a long breath.

“I hate working with the Yakuza,” Aizawa grumbled and worked out a crick in his neck.

“The *Yakuza*?!” Denki exclaimed in surprise. His eyes widened by several fractions and all of their mouths gaped open. “That was the fucking *Yakuza*—”

“—Yes,” Aizawa hissed. He shot a very pointed glare at Denki to be quiet. “Keep your voice down. That was the Yakuza heir, Chisaki Kai. He’s the leader of the Shie Hassaikai and they have a very *violent* grip on Tokyo and some surrounding lands.”

Katsuki ignored the chill on his neck when goosebumps rose up.

The Shie Hassaikai were notoriously venomous and had blackmail on the most influential political leaders in the country. If that was the heir, Katsuki decided he didn’t want to ever cross paths with them again.

“They’re not to be messed with, you hear me?” Aizawa said firmly. “Remember these are strictly clients who do shady business. Never give your name or address out to them, *ever*. They usually don’t go looking for trouble, but you never know if they need a pawn in their games. I’ve seen them set up innocent people all the time.”

All of them nodded.

Aizawa always gave good advice, and this was a large reality check for Katsuki. He was always surrounded by people he should be weary of. Yakuza. Crime Lords. Drug smugglers. Shady Politicians. Even though they were hitmen, they were all of these crooked people’s guns operating in the shadows. Just because they did business with these folks, didn’t mean they were allies in crime.

“I see you have folders in your hand,” Monoma said.

“Yes. You all have a new assignment,” Aizawa said. “This is why I called you all here, I didn’t expect that meeting with Chisaki to go over like that. But, The Company was hired to help a crime lord out in Osaka. After reading over the details, it seems like M-Unit is the best fit for the case.”

“Who’s the crime lord this time?” Sero asked. Aizawa handed them all their folders. Monoma, Shinsou and Katsuki were all handed green while Sero and Denki were given support folders with mission details.

“The client’s name is Akaguro Chizome.”

☽ ☽ ☽

Later that day they were all flown out to Osaka on Aizawa’s private jet.

The beautiful city sights were something they couldn't give much appreciation because they were shuffled into Chizome's headquarters to meet with the crime lord in his office.

The entirety of Chizome's boardroom was painted in a dull, gray color and sitting in his office was a single black rose in a vase full of water. On the walls were pinned up dead roses and tally marks like someone had engraved the marks with their bare fingernails. But what gave Katsuki the creeps the most was the man's chair was spiked in the back with metal rods and his necklace was made of human molars.

Sitting in that chair like a king was Chizome.

He was somehow both poised and rotten in the same breath like a beautiful still life of food that had been decaying for a year. His ink black hair was slicked back into a long, high ponytail and his deadly eyes felt like bullseyes whenever they landed on someone. The crime lord kept himself freshly draped in deep, red suits with shiny rings on each finger.

He smiled at all of them like they were flies.

As they discussed the assignment in the boardroom, Chizome interrupted Monoma and pulled out five, shiny black briefcases.

"To ensure the mission gets carried out well, I'm offering to pay you all more cash up front," Chizome said. "This cash is off record by the way. I know your company takes a commission for your service, which I think isn't right."

Sero frowned and Monoma and Shinsou exchanged glances. Denki stiffened beside him and Katsuki cocked his head curiously. Chizome smirked wider and snapped his fingers. All the bodyguards surrounding him each took a suitcase and walked around the wide, circle table. They placed a briefcase in each of their hands. Katsuki swallowed at how heavy it was—which meant there was a lot of fucking money inside.

Aizawa would kill them for something like this.

"We're not supposed to accept separate payments," Sero finally spoke. He pushed the briefcase across the well-polished table and crossed his arms. "All cash transactions have to go through our supervisor."

"I know," Chizome said. He plucked a piece of dust off his clean red suit. "Think of it as a nice gesture. I appreciate you all coming out to complete this assignment for me, I want to make sure you're paid handsomely."

All of them exchanged unsure glances. Sero was quietly shaking his head, cutting his eye at the crime lord. Denki seemed to side with what Sero was hinting at, however Shinsou had clicked open the briefcase and was counting the cash. Monoma followed the lead of his best friend.

Katsuki was stuck in the middle, tugged by conflicting emotions. All he could see were those unpaid bills on his mother's table and the possibility of her slipping up again.

Shinsou gave Sero an apologetic stare. “I have bills, Sero.”

“You get paid enough,” Sero chastised. “Taking extra is bad news.”

“We don’t get paid that much,” Monoma said sourly. “Look, it’s a one time thing. I’ve seen plenty of other agents take extra cash on the side. Doesn’t mean it’s anything bad. It’s basically a hallmark that we’re officially killers for hire, alright? Go buy yourself some new clothes or something with it.”

Sero looked at Shinsou and Monoma in disbelief. He turned towards Denki and Katsuki with pleading eyes. However, Denki caved once he clicked open the briefcase. Even though the yen wasn’t gold, it glittered just like it did. With a shaky hand, Denki reached forward and ran his fingers across the cash inside.

Denki turned towards Sero with a sad expression. Katsuki had never seen him sad.

“You know my mom is sick,” Denki whispered to Sero. He glanced down to the cash in his lap. “I was saving up for the operation, but this would cover it.”

Sero chewed on his bottom lip, clearly not okay with any of this.

Katsuki stared at the money in his lap.

Everyone was right to some degree.

Should they accept money from Chizome? Probably not. Aizawa made it a point even to tell them before they left not to trust the people they worked for. However, like Monoma said, everyone took extra cash on the side and bad things rarely happened from it. There was nothing the higher ups could do about it because what they were doing was *illegal*. And exactly like Denki pointed out, they all had loved ones to think about.

Katsuki prodded his tongue into his cheek as he considered his mother’s housing issue. If he could pay off her apartment in full, then she wouldn’t need to worry about bills. That would take a lot of stress off him, and he wouldn’t have to constantly check up on her and babysit.

“Is it clean?” Katsuki asked.

Chizome chuckled and nodded politely. “Of course. I have done all the work already to make sure you all can understand my gratitude for your services.”

“Alright. Then I’m going to keep the money,” Katsuki decided.

Katsuki clicked his briefcase shut.

Everyone whipped their heads towards him and Chizome’s smirk grew wider. The crime lord leaned against the table and folded his hands happily as he watched all the dominos fall into place.

“Me too,” Monoma said. “And keep your mouth *shut*, Sero.”

“Me as well,” Shinsou added.

Denki didn’t chime in with their choir but mouthed ‘sorry’ to Sero. He clicked the brief case closed and then placed it down at his side. Denki shamefully folded his hands in his lap quietly and hung his head.

Sero gawked at all of them, not believing what was occurring. He tried to plead one last time but none of them glanced in his direction, silently shutting him down.

When all of them were set in their stances, Sero still didn’t budge on his own. Disgust trickled into his eyes and he shook his head at all his teammates before letting out a disgruntled huff.

“I won’t be keeping the money,” Sero said firmly. “But I won’t tell Aizawa. Whatever shit you all get into, it’s your own damn fault. I won’t say I told you so.”

Monoma rolled his eyes and made some smart-ass quips. Shinsou told Sero to loosen up and Denki stayed as silent as Katsuki.

In retrospect, Katsuki wishes he had listened to Sero at that time. He was always the voice of reason in their chaotic group, but Katsuki had been too caught up in the idea that money could solve all his problems.

Katsuki looked across the table at the smug grin Chizome was wearing.

☽ ☽ ☽

When their crew got back to their lavish hotel room, everyone was quiet except Monoma and Shinsou. The pair didn’t seem to care about the way Sero was side eyeing them in disapproval. Denki was curling away from Sero, clearly ashamed of himself.

Katsuki carried himself indifferently. He wasn’t going to be as arrogant about taking extra money like Monoma and Shinsou per se, but he wasn’t fucking feeling guilty about it like Denki. Sero could glare at him all he wanted to but the fact stood that out of the five of them, Sero had the most normal fucking life. He had no right to judge any of them.

Before Katsuki went to bed that night, he deposited the money at the bank and sent his mother a text.

[You]: Here’s the money to pay off your car and apartment.

[Mom]: Thank you

He stared at those simple words on the screen for a while.

He didn’t understand why he felt hollow looking at them. The next notification on his phone was a bank withdrawal.

☽ ☽ ☽

When the next morning came, they met up at the shady warehouse in the woods where Chizome said to come. It was the dead of fucking winter and Katsuki was admittedly a little chilly as he stood there outside waiting.

He checked his watch a couple of times, curious as to where the hell Chizome was. This was a green folder assignment which meant they had to protect the bastard. Couldn't exactly protect someone who wasn't here.

"Chizome said to meet at this location, right?" Monoma asked curiously. He glanced around at the barren place oddly. "This doesn't seem correct."

"This is the spot according to the assignment details," Shinsou muttered. He glanced around, unsure as well. "I vote we dip if he doesn't come after an hour."

"We can't just abandon an assignment," Sero chastised.

"You're such a fucking uncles' boy," Monoma huffed. "I'm with Shinsou on this one. I'm not staying here in the middle of the night in winter, freezing my ass off because Chizome was late or gave the wrong coordinates."

"In case you forgot, all four of you accepted *extra* money from the man," Sero hissed. He glared deeply at Monoma. "He could fucking say we stole from him or something if we leave without notice—"

"—*Who are you*?!" A threatening voice suddenly cut into the chilly air in Korean.

All five of them froze.

Katsuki whirled around and his stomach dropped when he could see ten, unfamiliar men standing there with assault rifles locked and loaded. Their faces were angry, confused and on edge. Katsuki slowly put his hands up along with everyone else when his gut twisted.

"Uh, yo, do any of you speak Korean?" Denki whispered wearily when the man repeated his question again.

"*Tell me who are you? How did you find this place*?" The man said a lot more ferociously in the language they didn't understand. When none of them answered the ten men cocked their guns. "*Did filthy Chizome send you*?"

"Well, that name I fucking understood," Katsuki muttered quietly. "This is a set up."

"*So Chizome sent you! You're all little cockroaches*!" The man screamed. "*I'll kill you for trespassing. That'll send the message to Chizome that we are done with him. I would say tell your boss, but you will be sliced up into tiny pieces today*."

All the other men started muttering in the language Katsuki couldn't understand. Katsuki's anxiety and adrenaline spiked all at once. He tried to calm his breathing, but when the brittle winter cut through his flesh and the sight of blood lust glares encircled them, he knew they were fucked.

“Guys, we need to get out of here. *Now*,” Denki whispered, shaking slightly.

Then suddenly the sound of footsteps rushing from behind them occurred and all hell broke loose. Denki started screaming, Monoma drew his guns and Shinsou took out his rifle. Katsuki whipped his head to see who was charging at him, but before he could he was hit sharply on the temple with a blunt metal object.

His vision immediately shifted too black.

☽ ☽ ☽

The cold air slammed into his lungs when the sound of bullets, screams, and the feeling of his body being dragged against the snow woke him back up.

Katsuki tried to open his eyes, struggling to gain control of his limbs again. His whole world was spinning, and he felt like he was ready to puke. He winced when he could feel several gunshot wounds in his arms, legs and chest. It took him a moment to recognize he was being dragged and rushed out of a building he didn’t fucking remember entering.

The world underneath his feet was unstable and all he could hear was Denki’s screams in the background. Shinsou was trying to slap him back awake, and his usually cool demeanor was tossed to the side.

“Bakugou!” Shinsou screamed above the gunshots. “Bakugou! Get the fuck up!”

The desperation in his comrade’s voice was enough to violently pull Katsuki back to the land of the living. He jolted up at the same time Shinsou was hit by a flying bullet. Shinsou screamed as it lodged itself deep in his shoulder and he fell back into the snow.

Katsuki grabbed him, and quickly held him up in his arms. Katsuki yelled out in agony as he tried to work against the searing hot fresh wounds in his body. He had to get them somewhere safe. He had to he had to he had to—

All the thoughts in his head were compressed down to a single word: survive. Katsuki maneuvered swiftly, carrying Shinsou somewhere safe deep into the woods. The sound of rushing footsteps approached upon them as way more men than expected poured out of the warehouse.

“Shit,” Katsuki screamed and tried his best to reload his gun.

His fingers were trembling as he cocked his weapon and then concisely shot two men down. He aimed his weapon directly between their eyes and fired off, killing them instantly. Shinsou eventually rebounded and began to do the same. They worked quickly, killing one, two, three, four, five—ten men. However, more kept coming, and they were coming out fully loaded.

When they found a tree to take cover behind, Katsuki was losing count of the number of people flooding out of the scene. This wasn’t supposed to happen. What the fuck?

“I thought this was a green folder assignment,” Shinsou groaned. “Where the hell is the mark we’re supposed to be protecting?”

“Hell if I know,” Katsuki grunted. “We need to get out of here or kill everyone.”

Katsuki shot another man down who came too close to them.

“I hate gangsters,” Shinsou hissed as he applied more pressure to his wound.

From across the way, Katsuki could see Monoma and Sero sniping men from afar, and Denki trying to call for backup who might be in the area.

By the time someone from The Company arrived, the five of them had cleared out the scene. Dead, bloody bodies full of lead laid in the once clean snow soaking it all the way red. Katsuki had never seen such a sight. It was close to a massacre, all the lifeless figures stretched out. One man had gotten away, but none of them were well enough to chase after him.

Their backup from The Company was stunned by the scene. None of the five of them moved. Simply stayed kneeling in the scarlet-soaked snow. All their wounds were throbbing and Katsuki’s labored breathing was loud. He was kneeled over clutching his chest. Sero was trying to keep Denki awake after he had been hit upside the head. Monoma was clutching against a tree. Shinsou attempted to walk over to him but fell to his knees.

Slowly but surely, Katsuki lost consciousness.

As his face hit the cold snow, his memory transported him back to the safety of Tokyo. He could see the weeping angel covered in snow and feel the small hands that kept him warm. He wanted safety, and as his tortured body ached for it, the thought of the blurry faced boy comforted him.

☽ ☽ ☽

“Chizome. I’m going to fucking *kill* you,” Aizawa promised.

They were all standing at the HQ in Osaka and Aizawa had a shotgun in his hands ready to fire. The tensions in the room were thicker than anything Katsuki ever witnessed. On one half of the room was Chizome and his men, smirking happily and on the other half was The Company. Aizawa was standing in front of the five of them livid enough that his heated glare made *Katsuki* scared.

“You put my best unit of agents’ lives at risk because you lied about what the assignment was,” Aizawa seethed. “If they had been killed I would have shot you where you stand right now.”

“If they were killed they would have paid their debts to the universe,” Chizome said nonchalantly in some goddamn riddle. There wasn’t a drop of remorse in his eyes as he rolled the stem of a black rose between his fingers. “Killers'' lives have no *real* meaning.”

He looked over the five of them who were thoroughly beat up and bandaged nearly everywhere. All five of them stayed silent, unsure of what was going to happen.

“So, you did this to kill them?” Aizawa asked, hatred spilling into his words.

“No, I did this to put them to use. They’re all useless pawns at your company so I figured I would give their skills a spin.”

“Why not just pay for a goddamn red assignment?” Aizawa asked. “They were unprepared to handle that many men all at once.”

“I saw the price of red,” Chizome said slowly. He looked towards them and sneered. “Not a single one of them is worth that much. They didn’t even kill the main guy I was hoping they would. They let him scurry away like a goddamn roach.”

“Don’t ever contact me or The Company again,” Aizawa said in finality. “I returned your money and all future contracts with us are nullified per the damn clauses. Go fuck yourself.”

Katsuki swallowed at the mention of money. All of them cut their eyes at each other, realizing they had in fact fucked up. Monoma pressed his lips in a thin line. Shinsou held his breath and Denki looked like he was about to cry. Sero was glancing at Aizawa’s face then to Chizome’s—and Chizome’s all too perfectly painted face was grinning wide.

Katsuki started chants in his head that he would make it home without any conflict. They all turned around slowly, not saying a word about the money that was dealt under the table.

But as soon as Aizawa’s hand touched the door, Chizome’s deep chuckle stopped them.

“What about the money I paid these men privately?” Chizome announced.

Shinsou cursed under his breath and the ground underneath all their feet felt like it gave out. Katsuki sucked in his lips and closed his eyes begging for some black hole to swallow him up.

Aizawa stiffened and looked over his shoulder. “What are you talking about?”

“I paid those four extra.” Chizome pointed his long, boney finger at him, Denki, Monoma and Shinsou. “I thought we had an understanding that I paid them extra money to do an extra task for me. Or at least that’s what we agreed upon.”

“He’s *lying*,” Monoma objected immediately. He shook his head quickly when Aizawa looked at all of them like they had committed a grave deed. “We *never* agreed to kill a warehouse of people like that—”

“—Sure you did,” Chizome said. “That’s why you took my money. You knew what this assignment really was, I don’t know why you’re lying now.”

Katsuki was speechless. He felt so fucking *dumb*. Of course, it was a goddamn trap. This whole assignment was a fucking trap.

“Is that true?” Aizawa muttered. He looked at all of them with deep disappointment. “Did you take his money?”

“Y-Yes,” Denki admitted and Aizawa’s grip on the door handle tightened dangerously. “B-But he said it was just a nice thank you! I would not have gone anywhere thinking I had to *kill* someone, much less a building full of people!”

“Well, I had specified I only needed one person killed.” Chizome held up his pointer finger. “But that one person seems to have gotten away. So, this counts as a failed mission. I’ll be taking my money back now because this wasn’t part of our agreement.”

Monoma’s nostrils flared. “There was no goddamn agreement—”

“—Give him back his money.” Aizawa didn’t look at any of them. “You all should know better than to take money under the table. This is exactly why. Give him back his money and we’re cutting off all ties with this shit show before someone loses their life.”

Denki, Shinsou and Monoma all did as Aizawa said. They took off their large, black backpacks that were strapped to their person and started taking out the wads of cash. Cash that Katsuki already had deposited and fucking spent. As his colleagues handed over all the money and Chizome’s men counted it up, bile stuck to the back of Katsuki’s throat.

All eyes were on him.

Katsuki flexed his hands when he started to realized he fucked up greater than he ever thought he would.

“Bakugou, you too,” Aizawa said tiredly. “Give Chizome his money so we can leave.”

“I—” Katsuki licked his lips. Everyone glanced at him and Chizome seemed so satisfied by his floundering. “I don’t have the money.”

The corners of Aizawa’s mouth pulled all the way down. “What do you mean you don’t have the money?” Aizawa hissed. “He gave it to you yesterday, right? Where is it?”

“I sent it to my mom,” Katsuki whispered. “She texted me that she already spent it all.”

“Bakugou,” Aizawa said his name like he was already in the grave. All the blood drained from his face and left him visibly pale. “You need to get that money back.”

“I *can’t*,” Katsuki hissed. “I already used up all my funds this month for grocery, bills, the condo, the apartment and two car payments. The month left me with a tight budget.”

“Tsk. What an irresponsible little *boy*,” Chizome reprimanded. He looked beyond pleased. “Clearly someone needs some time to grow up and learn how to better juggle his finances. Did no one teach you never to blow your entire bank account all at once?”

No.

No one had taught him that. That fact cut Katsuki to have it shoved in his face.

Chizome rolled that black rose between his fingers again. The crime lord tilted his head at him with a sick grin.

“I want my money, *Bakugou*,” Chizome insisted. “If I don’t have it by the end of the day I’m going to assume you’re meaning to cross me like the sniveling *child* you are.”

That single word of ‘child’ triggered something deep in Katsuki. He gritted his teeth.

“How the hell have I crossed you?” Katsuki barked before he could stop himself. He whirled on Chizome, angry. He stepped forward to go get in that bastard’s fucking face but quickly Monoma grabbed his arm and held him back. “I should wipe that stupid grin off your face for this. You have no idea who the *fuck* I am.”

“I actually have a couple theories,” Chizome said amusingly. He lowered the black rose and gently placed it on his desk. “You could be some plain, poor boy from the countryside with a bad temper. But maybe you’re the bastard son of one of the most murderous men in history. Or possibly, you’re The Scarlet Eyed Killer.”

Everyone in the room froze.

Aizawa cursed under his breath and Katsuki’s bones rattled. Katsuki reeled back a bit, confused but it all suddenly clicked into place.

“You knew who I was this whole time,” Katsuki whispered. “What exactly is this?”

“An offer,” Chizome explained. “After the way you killed your poor father, the police aren’t the only people looking for you, I hope you know. A lot of powerful people want you on their side yet you’re wasting your time being trained by this *wash out*. Rage like yours needs the chance to flourish.”

Chizome cut his eyes towards Aizawa who was eerily silent. He was poised with his shotgun, watching everyone in the room carefully.

“You have two choices,” Chizome continued. He leaned back in his chair and studied the dead roses he had pinned on the wall. “Come work for me on an assignment and pay off the money you’ve spent or give me the money back in a day.” Chizome’s wolfish grin spread wider. “We can arrange something, and you can go hunt down the insect you let get away. Who knows, maybe you’ll find you enjoy working for someone who rewards your rage versus tries to suffocate it. I’m a great mentor.”

“You can kiss my ass,” Katsuki jeered, and he spat on the ground. “I’m not paying you shit and I’m not going to work for you. I would rather kill you than ever have you mentor me you sick fucker.”

Chizome glowered. He looked down at the wad of spit on the ground in disgust. “You’re more disrespectful than I anticipated.”

“I haven’t even *begun* to disrespect you,” Katsuki jabbed. “I’ll put a knife in your throat before I let you tell me what to do.”

Chizome raised an eyebrow. “Big promises.”

“Bakugou. We need to leave,” Aizawa warned slowly.

Quietness washed over the scene. Everyone stayed still, surveying each other’s trigger fingers. In the tension, Katsuki could have sworn he heard Denki’s heartbeat. Without another word they all backed up, and it looked as though Chizome was truly about to let them go.

When they finally walked through the door, Chizome uttered one last warning Katsuki would never forget.

“Whether debts are fair or not, they are debts,” Chizome said slowly. “They have to be paid one way or another. Sometimes they are paid in regret. Debts are debts.”

Katsuki would come to find out those words were true.

☽ ☽ ☽

Months went by with no word from Chizome.

During this time, Aizawa had tried to urge him to give back whatever amount of money he had been given like Shinsou, Monoma, and Denki had. But Katsuki was prideful and thick headed. He didn’t like the way Chizome approached him, calling him a goddamn *child*. Then the bastard tried to trap him like some animal on a leash to do his dirty work. He would teach the man a lesson this way, and if someone came up to him, Katsuki was confident he would devour them.

But it was fucking *strange* that nothing happened.

It kept Katsuki on high alert. Every corner he turned he was on his toes, gun secretly loaded in his leather jacket. He forced himself to be sharper on assignments. So much so that Aizawa and Monoma noticed his paranoid shift—but nothing ever came.

Katsuki tried to make sense of it, because that sleazy bastard was always known for getting what he wanted. Katsuki reasoned after a while of silence, maybe the man was scared of him. He *was* the notorious Scarlet Eyed Killer who brutally murdered Muscular in cold blood.

It probably was no secret either amongst the underground crowd the man was his father.

Katsuki foolishly thought he was untouchable for months of silence. Six months of nothing occurred to the point it lulled him into a false deception of security.

During this time, he visited his mother. He brought her pink carnations every time he dropped by because he enjoyed the cheerful look on her face. She would call him thoughtful and then tell him about her day. He did his assignments, hung out with his friends. He went on his spree of ‘dates’ and soon it felt like Chizome was all talk—

—Until he wasn’t.

This summer afternoon had been blazing. The temperatures were record high and Katsuki fanned the hem of his black shirt to catch some breeze. He had his sunglasses pulled down on his eyes, blocking out the sun and preventing anyone who might recognize him from his eyes alone.

He had been walking back from purchasing another bundle of pink carnations from the flower shop when he got a call from Sero. He answered easily, not thinking too much about anything, unknowing to the shadow of the grim reaper hanging on his shoulder.

“What’s up, Sero?” Katsuki asked as he strolled along. The crowds of the city were packed with their usual density and wide varieties of colorfully decorated people.

“What are you doing right now?” Sero asked, some mischief hanging in his voice. “Want to get into some trouble with your fellow migraines?”

“I’m about to go to my mom’s,” Katsuki explained. “You know I go to visit her on Tuesdays, Thursdays and Saturdays.”

“Oh, *boo*. You goddamn mama’s boy,” Sero said unhappily. “Do you think you can skip today? Denki found this pretty sick underground club scene. It has a bunch of really cool drinks, and I heard the guys who come there are *really* cute—”

“—Pass,” Katsuki said. “If you’re trying to sway me with cute guys, it’s not going to work. I had my daily fuck already. I have no desire to talk to any cute guys.”

“I forgot how crude you are,” Sero grumbled. “Why do you spend so much time with your mom, dude? Not knocking you or whatever. I wish my mom gave me that type of attention. But like, we’re all just kind of curious.”

Katsuki pushed his tongue into the side of his cheek. He thought about his response honestly and carefully. “I feel like I’m playing catch up to be honest for all the time my mom and I missed when I was growing up.”

“…What do you mean?”

“I dunno, this is gonna sound really fucking corny, but.” Katsuki paused to lick his lips. “She wasn’t the best parent when I was a kid. She did the best she *could* but it wasn’t enough for someone my age, y’know? It’s weirdly nice that she’s finally mentally here. I just want to try to play catch up. I’ve gotten her as a good mom for two years so far. I can’t remember when I was younger. All I can remember was when she started being not so great.”

“Damn,” Sero whispered. He whistled low. “I didn’t expect such a deep answer from you. I didn’t know things were like that for you growing up, man. Sorry to hear that but nice to hear it’s gotten better.”

“Thanks, Sero. Yeah, it’s gotten a lot better,” Katsuki whispered. He smiled a bit, happy to finally say the word ‘*better*’ with weight behind it. “I promise when I feel like things with my mom are fully okay again, I’ll come out to hang with you all.”

As they had this convo, Katsuki walked to his mother's place. He entered the building, took the elevator up and watched the numbers light up. He felt content as the slow rise of the metal machine reeled him upwards. When the elevator dinged, Katsuki exited through the chunky metal doors with Sero still yammering in his ear.

"I'm holding you to that man! No offense, but Monoma scares away *everyone*," Sero groaned. "Him and Shinsou are *so* socially awkward."

"God, you're so fucking right." Katsuki chuckled. He dug out his keys from his pants pockets and pushed it in the lock with a cocky grin. "I swear it's like someone took a stick, broke it in two and stuck it up each of their asses—"

He swung open the door and all the words died in his throat.

Katsuki's eyes locked on to the cold, dead body in the room.

His heart dropped down to the floor and his stomach squeezed in nausea as he tried to comprehend what he was seeing. Red eyes. Red eyes the same as his were lifeless and dull staring back at him. The fragile, petite body was unmoving and had a gaping mouth. Blonde hair was caked with red speckles. His mother's body was laid out on the ground, ashen gray and pooled by her own blood that was leaking from the bullet hole in her skull.

Katsuki dropped the phone when his world spun into motion. He ran towards her with the bouquet of carnations in his hand. His voice splintered and he started screaming out 'mom' in an ear shattering tone as pink petals trailed in his steps. He sank harshly to his knees beside her stale body. His mind rapidly raced with thoughts too quick to catch as he stared at what was in front of him.

There was so much red.

"Bakugou?" Sero's voice from the forgotten phone could be heard. The once bubbly tone used was now on high alert and concerned. "Bakugou, are you okay?"

Katsuki's voice was stolen from him as he stared at the lifeless body of his mother.

The thick blood pooled from her body onto his pants as he sat there trying to wrap his mind around what he was seeing. He nudged her body with his trembling hands like she was simply asleep, but she didn't move. She didn't blink. She didn't breathe. She was dead. She was dead. She was dead. She was *killed*—

"Hey Bakugou, answer me. Is everything okay?"

Sero's voice was nothing but white noise piercing through Katsuki's mind. He couldn't comprehend anything as long as his eyes were locked on the ghastly visual in front of him.

Katsuki choked back a sob. Those stinging tears that always threatened to fall appeared once more, but like always, those tears never fell. His eyes were wild as they darted around the lavish apartment. He searched for an intruder, calling out angrily to whatever ghost it was but

found no one but the phantoms of his own mind. He studied the way her body had fallen, mangled and unnatural right in front of the open window.

“Okay, Bakugou. I’m going to call Aizawa and we’re coming over there now. You’re scaring me.”

Katsuki wanted to scream, he wanted to yell and respond to Sero but he found himself trapped in time. His eyes refused to peel away from the bullet hole in his mother’s skull. He could see the ghost visual of Chizome laughing at his misery and giving him that sickly grin.

By the time Aizawa and Sero arrived, Katsuki was still kneeled in the middle of the living room, curled over Mitsuki’s dead body. The blood had soaked through his pants, shirt, and jacket, staining him in deep red that he would never be able to rub off as he sobbed over her. Between their bodies, Katsuki was clutching the pink carnations so tight to his chest that they suffocated in his grip.

Aizawa made the first move, walking on the ground like it was ready to shatter. He kneeled down carefully and touched Katsuki’s shoulder without saying a word.

“She’s *dead*.” Katsuki didn’t recognize his own voice.

☽ ☽ ☽

Aizawa had tried talking to him afterwards, but Katsuki couldn’t hear anything. Every word spoken was noisy static. It went in one ear and out the other.

Katsuki sat there, unsure of what to do with himself as he waded in his mother’s apartment. Investigators from The Company were moving all about, taking her stuff, and Aizawa was trying his best to take charge for him. The elder man steeled his emotions and tried to act like a leader in the situation, but his distress was clear as day. The bags underneath Aizawa’s eyes were darker. Heavier. Even he was feeling the weight of Mitsuki’s sudden murder.

When the last of his mother’s things were picked up and no trace of any killer could be found, Katsuki’s heart broke even more.

“I’m sorry, Bakugou,” Aizawa said. His voice was mournful, and he clenched his fists, keeping in his rage. “There’s no trace of any evidence. There was just a single bullet, and we can’t figure out how to trace it.”

Katsuki held back from screaming.

He looked at the terrible blood stain that was soaked into the wood.

Who did this?

As he stared at the way the blood was caked in the cracks of the floorboards, a flower delivery boy awkwardly cleared his throat at the doorway.

“Hello? Is there a Bakugou Katsuki here?” The delivery boy asked.

Katsuki tore his eyes away from the floor and Aizawa peered around the busy people bustling in and out. Some curious eyes looked as well. The boy standing there was dressed in a blue and white uniform, and nearly looked dorky with his hat on. His eyes were weary though, and an anxious aura surrounded him as he glanced around at all the strange, suspicious looking employees from The Company.

“I’m Bakugou Katsuki,” Katsuki answered loudly. His voice was hoarse from using it infrequently.

The boy nodded, a little skittish as he stared down at the strange flowers in his hands. He stepped into the apartment and everyone inside froze as the petite man walked inside. A feeling like spiders nestling under his skin occurred when Katsuki caught sight of the flowers. It was a large bundle of wilted, black roses with red paint splattered across them.

“These are a delivery for you,” the boy said in a hush whisper, terror in his eye.

Aizawa’s face became disquieted as Katsuki was handed the flowers that had a scarlet ribbon tied around them. Aizawa peered from over Katsuki’s shoulder to see exactly what he was seeing. Sitting neatly tied to the flowers was a tiny card. Katsuki flipped the white card around to see a neat cursive message. Both him and Aizawa read the message, and when they did, all the pieces clicked in place.

Debts are Debts.

— *Chizome* .

Katsuki crushed the card in his hands and gritted his teeth together.

His fists clutched painfully tight as pure fury boiled inside of him. His nostrils flared with anger as the dark spirited in him howled loudly from deep inside of his core. Katsuki’s face twisted into a deadly scowl as the mocking laughter of Chizome played in the back of his head.

“I’ll kill him,” Katsuki promised with a broken voice. He didn’t notice that his nails had broken through the skin on his palms had drew blood. “I’m going to fucking *kill* him.”

☽ ☽ ☽

His mother’s funeral was something Katsuki had never given thought.

He always assumed it would be something he’d approach far in the future when they both had lived their lives. By that time she’d have silver hair, healed from his father’s death, and recovered fully into a functional person. But now, that was robbed from both of them. Cut short like most things in Katsuki’s life were.

There was a specific irony in the fact this was Katsuki’s first funeral.

He had painted himself red many times, stealing life away from so many people daily. But he never had to dress in black like all the families he caused to have missing links. He wondered if this is how any of them felt at the funerals for their loved ones. How many times over had

he inflicted this same type of pain on someone? He had never thought about it until now. One person dies and the ripples of their absence stretched out further in time than anyone could ever calculate.

Katsuki dressed accordingly with Aizawa's guidance. His suit was a crisp black with a black tie and a black button up. He had black pants and black socks and shoes. In his hands he held the pink carnations his mother always loved. A part of him was foolish feeling like this was another opportunity to make her smile, one last time. He could imagine her hugging him and telling him he was such a good son like always.

But he was rudely awakened that she would never smile again during the service.

Her unmoving body laid in that white, satin lined coffin. Her skin was blankly gray. Her eyes were closed and her hands were delicately crossed over her chest. She looked so peaceful for the first time. Not distressed. Not drunk. Not paranoid. She looked like she was finally resting after running from her problems for so long.

When she was lowered into the ground, all of Katsuki's visions of the future being better followed.

After the service concluded, Katsuki sat on a wooden bench outside of the cemetery. He still held the pink carnations in his hand. He didn't have the will power to actually put them in the ground with her. He plucked the petals from the flowers one by one.

His thoughts were heavy.

She was getting better. Finally, she had finally been getting fucking *better* and Chizome fucking robbed him of it.

He didn't know how long he had sat there mutilating the carnations in his hands. By the time Aizawa found him, half of the bouquet was tweaked of its petals. Aizawa had a grim look etched into his face. The elder man didn't say anything, simply sat next to him in his all black outfit as well. Katsuki's thoughts were full of Chizome. He couldn't get rid of the vision of that rotting smile even if he fucking wanted to.

"Whatever happened to Asashi's daughter after I killed him?" Katsuki asked quietly.

Aizawa cut his eye towards him. He looked at the flower petals that fell to the ground steadily. "Are you sure that's a question you want to ask right now?"

"Yes," Katsuki said. "What happened to her?"

"She went on to be a doctor." Aizawa let out a deep sigh. "She's finding her peace and keeping other people's loved ones alive. She made it part of her life mission to help save people's lives since she never was able to figure out what happened to her father."

Noble.

Katsuki nodded his head in approval. "That's good. I was half expecting maybe she would try to avenge her father one day."

“No. Camie isn’t like that,” Aizawa said. He shrugged and scratched behind his head. “What makes you ask that question today?”

“Because I’m going to kill Chizome,” Katsuki announced, eyes unfocused. He angrily plucked more petals, not slowing his steady stream of destruction. “I wanted to know if there were any loose ends that might prevent me from doing so.”

Aizawa gave him a pitiful expression. “Bakugou…”

“He killed my goddamn *mom*, Aizawa,” Katsuki hissed. His words were lathered in loathing. “I want to make sure it’s even.”

“Revenge doesn’t help anything, Katsuki,” Aizawa warned. He worked his jaw and shook his head with conflict swirling in his eyes. “Trust me, kid. *I know*. I have been down this path before. The path of revenge isn’t pretty. It’s a mistake and you’ll wind up hurting people close to you.”

Katsuki scoffed.

“People close to me?” Katsuki mocked slightly with a sneer. “And who exactly would that be? I have *no one*. My mother was the only fucking person I had. My father is dead. I murdered my biological father. I don’t have anyone else. I can’t hurt people who aren’t *there*.”

Aizawa shifted and let the silence pan out.

“Katsuki. You’re hurting,” Aizawa eventually said and turned his body towards him. “I know you are *deeply* hurting, and I know how horrible loss can feel. But killing Chizome isn’t going to make you hurt less. You can’t solve loss with more loss. Killing Chizome is not going to heal you.”

Katsuki shook his head. “You’re misunderstanding me, old man. I’m not trying to heal. I’m trying to make someone bleed.”

Aizawa made a pained face. “…I thought I raised you better than that.”

“*Raised me*?” Katsuki parroted. He turned to Aizawa with bloodshot eyes, clouded with rage and hurt.

“I meant taught,” Aizawa quickly corrected. “I thought I taught you better than that.”

“No. You meant raise me.” Katsuki sarcastically sneered. “Is that what you think? Do you think you fucking raised me?”

Katsuki glared sharp, unforgiving daggers deep into the elder man’s skin when he got no reply. Katsuki chuckled ironically and twisted his words like knives.

“Let me be clear. No one has *ever* fucking raised me, because if they had, I wouldn’t be a goddam hitman for hire,” Katsuki hissed. “You did not raise me. Not then, not now, and I’m too goddamn old to be *raised* ever in the future. You’re *not* my fucking parent. All my

parents are dead. The last one was lowered into the ground *today*. Don't you *ever* say some shit like that to me again."

"I didn't mean it like that," Aizawa said quietly.

"Then what did you mean?"

No answer came but the howling wind.

Katsuki shook his head in disgust and stood up from the bench. He tossed the carnations down to the ground with disdain and walked away.

He left Aizawa on the bench by himself with his mistake. Hurt danced across the elder man's face, and a heavy part of his bruised heart wilted for Katsuki. He wanted to jump up and chase him down, but he didn't. He stopped himself, unsure of what had transpired.

When Aizawa looked down to the once beautiful bundle of pink carnations, they had been plucked clean.

☽ ☽ ☽

The weeks following his mother's death felt foreign.

He had always lived to make sure *they* were safe. But now, without her, Katsuki didn't exactly know what he was living for. He realized that all his efforts were for her. Never him. He would have never killed that man if not for her. He would have never taken this job if not for her. Everything was always about her and always had been.

All the bright colors from his life were drained into nothing. Every carnation he glanced at felt like it wilted to match him. He sagged his shoulders more, was quieter, standoffish and had a dangerously short temper. He ended up snapping on Monoma one day, purely because the other blond had walked a little bit too close to him once in the office.

After that, Aizawa put him on bereavement leave.

Well, he forced him.

"I don't need a fucking *break*. I need to find that bastard and slit his goddamn *throat*," Katsuki grumbled firmly when Aizawa told him to go home.

"For those sentences alone, I am going to make you take an extra two weeks," Aizawa said. The elder man shook his head and barely looked at him. "Come back when you're feeling less homicidal. I need you at your best and your best isn't when you're focused on violence alone. You lost your last living parent. You need to take some time to do self-care and recalibrate."

"What the fuck is self-care?" Katsuki asked.

Aizawa had opened his mouth and closed it. The elder man shook his head. "Go home, Bakugou. Get some rest. I'll see you in a month."

He was promptly escorted out of The Company and locked out. The guards took his ID and keys to get inside of the building and left him in the cold. Katsuki stood there, baffled as he gawked at the doors. He tried to ignore the part of him that was angry and slightly betrayed by Aizawa. His supervisor could barely fucking look at him, and he worried that it was because of *pity*.

Katsuki went to his apartment that night and was faced with the realization that he didn't know what the fuck he was doing.

He had far more money than he needed now that he only had his own bills to pay. He didn't make trips to the grocery store anymore for two people. He didn't stop by the flower shop anymore. He didn't view everything as him *and* his mother. He was forced to view everything as just him—and he had never done that before.

It was terrifying because Katsuki didn't know how to live for himself, and he was twenty years old.

He had a hard time getting out of bed, and that hungry spirit inside of him was the only thing keeping him going. With its jagged tooth smile, it told him every day to wake up, get dressed and track down Chizome. The vicious rumbling of revenge pulsed through his veins as he focused solely on making the score card even. He would make sure to plant a bullet in Chizome's forehead just like the man had done to his mother.

It didn't take long to find himself utterly consumed in his obsession.

The vision of his dead mother wouldn't leave him. The vision of Chizome promising to make him feel pain wouldn't leave him either. It wasn't before long, that those two memories blended together cruelly until he could *see* Chizome being the one to pull the trigger.

His grief filled in the gaps in his memory like glue, piecing all the missing images together. When Katsuki was alone at night, too weighed down by his hurt to get out of bed, he could envision it all. He could picture Chizome or one of his goons climbing in through his mother's window and swiftly landed a bullet in her skull right as she screamed.

Those morbid thoughts alone were enough fuel for Katsuki to keep moving. He was running on pure spite, but he needed it. The only thing that could save him was his anger—like it always had.

Katsuki eventually began to stalk the gangster's movements. He figured out where the man's HQ was, but he found out quickly the bastard never traveled without his deadly possie. The ones he kept in his inner circle were brutes. They killed without blinking and had sharp shooting skills that rivaled Katsuki's.

On one particular night, Katsuki stalked Chizome a little too closely. He was stationed out of where he learned to be the abandoned building he did his work in. As the gangster exited the doors, Chizome had stopped walking with his crew. He slowly creeped his eyes upwards in the dark to set sights on Katsuki camouflaged in all black with his gun pointed.

They locked eyes and the energy in the atmosphere surged like electricity. Several guns drew in the blink of an eye and his face was covered with tiny red dots. With a rush of adrenaline, Katsuki quickly ducked away, laying low on the ground. He squeezed his eyes shut, expecting a rainstorm of bullets.

However, he was met with nothing.

Confusion gripped him when the silence was a little too crisp. Why wasn't he made into a perfect opportunity for target practice?

When he peaked back over the ledge of the roof, Chizome and his inner circle had vanished. Katsuki pointed his gun in the darkness, looking for where they went but they had dispersed, leaving him alone on the roof by himself.

When Katsuki arrived home that evening, he ripped his ski mask off his exhausted face and placed his sniper gun on his expensive glass table. He was preparing to go lay down, but before he could relax a loud pounding on his door occurred.

Katsuki frowned, wondering who it could be. Maybe it was Chizome, here to finish off his fucking bloodline. Katsuki grabbed his rifle again and peaked out of the peep hole in the door —only to see Aizawa glaring at him through the fish-eyed lens. Judging by the pissed off expression he was wearing, Katsuki knew this was going to be tiresome.

He opened the door, and he was right. Aizawa barged in, slamming the door hard enough to probably shake the whole building and locked it tight. He whirled on Katsuki with the rage of a thousand storms.

“What the *fuck* is this I am hearing about you stalking Chizome?” Aizawa demanded.

Katsuki shrugged his shoulders and glared at his supervisor. He put his gun back down on the table and turned around.

“I don’t know what you’re talking about, old man—”

“—Cut the bullshit with me!” Aizawa snapped loudly, anger in full swing. He slammed his fist on the wall and it shook violently under his strength. “I have gotten a goddamn *threat* on *your* behalf because you crept too goddamn close to him. Have you learned *nothing*?!”

“I’ve learned that that bastard deserves far more than a bullet in his skull,” Katsuki muttered nonchalantly, not fazed by Aizawa’s seething. “Sure, I crept too close to him, but the fact is I got *close*. I can get closer if I try harder. And when I do, I’m going to give him the same treatment I gave Muscular.”

“Stop this,” Aizawa begged. His voice cracked desperately as he tried to cut through Katsuki’s hurt to speak some sense into him. “Chizome is no one to be casually messing around with. He already killed Mitsuki, but if you fuck around he has no issue picking apart everything until *you* fall apart. He’s going to make this personal even further if you keep fucking around.”

Katsuki flicked his hand at him and turned away. “I don’t care.”

“Bakugou—”

“—I *said* I don’t fucking *care*.”

Aizawa let out a tired exhale and screamed, “Do you have a death wish?!”

“And what if I do?!” Katsuki yelled back, whirling around with tears clutching his eyes.

Aizawa’s eyes grew wider by several fractions.

Katsuki’s chest heaved with realization of what he admitted. It flowed out easily, tipping off his tongue like a terrible prophecy. His chest splintered in uncountable fractures, damaged by his racing mixed emotions. Rage. Hurt. Desperation. Self-loathing. All these emotions pulled on him until he felt himself buckle under their weight.

“What if I do want to die?” Katsuki said slowly. His anger faded away into despair. “What if that’s what I think is best?”

Aizawa’s expression softened, and he carefully stepped towards the wilting young soul.

“Katsuki…”

“I—I don’t know how to fucking function,” Katsuki admitted shamefully. He gestured wildly around to all the shiny, beautiful things in his apartment. “I’m sitting here in this goddamn place going crazy because the fucking person I always had to make sure *lived* is *dead* because of me. *Me*. Not because of some dumb shit *she* did—it was *me* in the end. I was supposed to be the *responsible* one and I got her killed being so goddamn *stupid*. I-I should’ve given the money back like you said. You warned me and I didn’t fucking listen and I got her killed.”

Aizawa looked down to the ground and his eyes skirted off to the side.

“Maybe I should go get myself killed by Chizome,” Katsuki chuckled sadly. “At least then it’ll be even. The right fucking person will be in the grave.”

He walked away from Aizawa, suddenly too tired to keep standing.

Katsuki walked over to the couch and hunched over. The feeling of the leather underneath him felt pointless. He kept thinking about what would have happened to them if he never took this job—would she still be alive?

“Your mother wouldn’t want you to think like this,” Aizawa muttered slowly. He sat down next to Katsuki on the couch. He folded his hands pensively and exhaled loudly. “She wanted what was best for you, Katsuki. Which means, living your life and not throwing it away.”

“I think I already have thrown it away,” Katsuki said sadly. “I…I don’t know what to do with myself anymore. I’m useless.”

“You’re not useless.”

“I am,” Katsuki insisted. “I can’t fucking do anything besides kill. It’s all I was made for.” He looked down at his hands and saw the invisible blood caked up to the sky. “If that’s all I’m good for, then the fucking least I can do is kill Chizome. My mother was a spiteful ass woman, she would want me to slit his throat. She believed in evening the scales, not turning the other cheek.”

“Yes, Mitsuki was spiteful,” Aizawa said tiredly. “But she shouldn’t be your guide. You’re sounding a little too much like me right now.”

“You?” Katsuki scoffed, not believing it. “You treat death too surgically. I doubt you would understand what I’m feeling right now.”

Aizawa scratched lazily at his chin and shrugged. His eyes became slightly unfocused as he looked up at the ceiling fan.

“My son, Koji, found out what I do for a living one day,” Aizawa said suddenly.

Katsuki froze on the spot, not expecting the conversation to turn there. Aizawa *always* kept his past shielded and no one at The Company spoke about his son. People who were around when it happened were long gone by now, and Aizawa never offered up the information anymore. Katsuki made sure to keep quiet as Aizawa continued.

Aizawa smiled bittersweetly. “He was disgusted with me. He couldn’t even look in my direction without seeming like he was going to throw up. His mother at the time had looked at me the same way when I eventually told her what I did.”

Katsuki glanced curiously towards his supervisor, like he was finally seeing him for the first time.

“They both moved away and told me to only contact when absolutely needed. They thought I was a monster.” Aizawa opened his hands and stared at the scars wrapping around his palms. “Then unfortunately, I had a deal gone wrong as well one day too. I wasn’t firm enough with the gangster we were dealing with. He took it upon himself to get back at me and he did it by killing my son and his mother. Then he left their bodies for me to find in my house because he thought we were close.”

Katsuki was stunned.

He never could have considered that was what happened.

“They died hating me,” Aizawa whispered, pain deep in his voice. “I hated myself so much in that moment too, and I told myself if I could go after that gangster it would feel better. I ended up finding him too.”

“…Did you kill him?”

“I did,” Aizawa answered simply. “I shot him seventy-four times.”

Katsuki tried to picture Aizawa killing in passion, but he was stunted and could only imagine a blank vision. Aizawa was a lot of things, but *passionate* about killing was not one. He

committed murder surgically, like it was purely an obligation and he always made sure to do it in the most precise way possible. Shooting someone that many times went against everything he was as a person.

“But I felt nothing. With each bullet, I felt not a single damn thing,” Aizawa said plainly. His eyes glazed over, and his brows pinched together. “I kept pulling the trigger and reloading because I was *sure* that sense of satisfaction would kick in at some point. I thought I would feel better—but I never did. Seventy-four bullets and not a single glimmer of happiness about it.”

Katsuki frowned.

As tragic as that story was, he struggled to believe that part about no satisfaction was fucking true. Aizawa could just be leveraging this story to try to draw Katsuki out of his fit of spite. If Katsuki had the opportunity, he would be more than gleeful to put that much lead into Chizome’s body. He’d pull the trigger with a twisted smirk and relish in the bloodlust.

Maybe Aizawa wasn’t cut out to be a killer in the same way he was.

“When I try to tell you to act from a place of protection and not rage, it’s not because I think it’s easier,” Aizawa whispered. “It’s because it’s what’s best. The path of anger is always worse. I lost so many friends, and the few people who did love me, I pushed them away in the process. I was so obsessed with finding that gangster I couldn’t see my life fall apart all around me. When I did realize it—it was too late. I couldn’t take back what I had done or said from trying to seek out revenge.”

Katsuki didn’t say much more and decided not to press further.

He knew in his mind that one day he would get his revenge on Chizome and even it out for his mother—but maybe that day wasn’t today. Or tomorrow. Or any time soon when he considered how heavy his heart was feeling. Aizawa wasn’t going to let him follow in his footsteps of spite, he saw himself in him too much.

“If you want to come back to work, I’m going to give you green folders,” Aizawa muttered after a while. He didn’t look at Katsuki as he said this. “I’ll reinstate you in red folders when I think you’re ready and you stop acting like such a goddamn idiot.”

“Fine.” There was no point in arguing.

Aizawa and Katsuki awkwardly stayed there on the couch side by side for a while. Katsuki half expected his supervisor to walk out now that the lecture was finished. Aizawa looked exhausted, dragged down by the mayhem Katsuki had caused.

“I heard the new All Might movie was decent,” Katsuki grumbled after a while. He didn’t look at Aizawa when he said this. He reached for the remote and turned on his flat screen television. “Do you want to watch it?”

“Sure,” Aizawa grumbled back.

They watched the movie together side by side in silence.

☽ ☽ ☽

When Katsuki proved he was stable again, Aizawa started to give him yellow folders to ease him back into his usual flow once more. The blood lust for Chizome had died off slowly, not because he had forgotten but because he was so distracted by that green goddamn *menace*.

Deku continued to be everywhere.

Absolutely *everywhere*.

How the hell could one tiny ass man manage to be such a goddamn pain in his side? Everywhere he turned he saw that freckled face like a nightmare.

“You’re getting a bit slow now,” Deku teased one night when Katsuki missed landing a bullet in his skull. “Off your game?”

But, as much as he hated to admit it—and truly, Katsuki fucking *hated* to admit it—*Deku* pulled him out of his spiral of vengeance long enough not to get his ass fired. He had been so consumed in the thoughts of painting Chizome red that he lost sight of himself. Seeing Deku forced him to think of himself and how there were other people in the world other than his mother.

When his mood began to stabilize, Katsuki realized every time he pulled the trigger, he was not motivated to do this any longer.

His mother was dead. He did this whole thing for her. And now that she was gone, he didn’t have to anymore. Which meant he could move on.

He could picture a soft sunset on a horizon that he never could envision before. The thought of it was warm, enlightening and it came to him clearer and clearer with every passing day. It was the first time he could think about the future without having to worry about the present. It was a sad realization how much she always weighed him down.

Beyond the horizon he could see visions of himself somewhere else in life. Possibly a place less red and not full of death. In the back was the sound of a soft violin and he could crisply hear ‘The Dance of The Love Birds’ for the first time in years. He thought about the boy from Tokyo for the first time in a long while and wished he had a way to contact him or even remember what he looked like.

As time passed, the green folders started to turn yellow then eventually they bled into red once more.

The growing need for red folder hitmen was rising quickly. The Company was getting more clients who were politicians and, ironically enough, politicians needed more people killed than they needed protection.

When Katsuki made the shift back over to red folders, he was twenty-one.

His world shifted from green to red. The unnamed green-eyed man was once more just a small annoyance in the background of his life until his next green assignment. But after the death of his mother, Katsuki began hanging out with the migraine unit more. He found that he actually did get along with them more than he thought, and they became close enough to be considered best friends.

Sero and Denki started dating at some point when he was twenty-two. Katsuki remembered how hard he had frowned at that in disgust. He still fucking hated romance—it was so pointless to him.

“You’re really never going to date someone?” Monoma asked with a sarcastic smile. “What? Is dating above The Scarlet Eyed Killer?”

Katsuki fiddled with his ring finger, toying with an invisible fabric ring that was lost with the rest of his childhood.

“It’s stupid to me,” Katsuki had answered with a handsome smirk. He hid the discomfort in his chest at the mention of romance when the blurry faced boy snuck in his head again. “I’ll stick to being the whore of the group to make you extras look better. I don’t have any interest in being a braindead lovesick fool.”

Everyone around him had laughed. They all tacked on with jokes, adding to the punchline.

“Of course, Bakugou isn’t interested in romance, he’s one of Japan’s most wanted,” Sero had said harmlessly.

“Yeah, plus, I can’t even imagine him being soft,” Denki snickered. “He probably would stab himself before ever trying to be *gentle* with someone.”

“I don’t even think he *can* be gentle,” Shinsou stated like it was a compliment. “Have you seen how he carries himself? He fucking shoved the guy in the club last week for just coming too close to him. Besides, Bakugou has always taken pride in being rough around the edges. Who are we to say he has to change?”

“Cheers to that,” Monoma laughed. “Bakugou, forever The Scarlet Eyed Killer. Fuck romance.”

Katsuki laughed along with them, agreeing to all the statements. “Yeah, fuck romance.”

He’d never mention how each of those comments stuck to him. And he’d never talk about how those few simple words were all the confirmation Katsuki needed to never try to find love. He was a killer, not a lover. But more importantly, he would always remain a loner.

Later that night, he distantly wondered how the blurry faced boy was doing.

☽ ☽ ☽

The next year went by with no issues. Running into Deku became routine on green folder assignments and red folder assignments were just technical work to him. By the time Katsuki

was twenty-three he was counting down the days for his retirement. He hadn't told Aizawa just yet—but he figured he would cross that bridge when he got there.

However, when the phone rang one dusk colored evening, it changed everything Katsuki would know to be true.

He could probably vividly recall this fateful evening until the day he died. He remembered laying on his couch, searching classical music classes to distract himself. The loss of his mother hung over his head like a dark storm cloud that followed him around.

The phone had run thrice. The first time, he ignored it. He was confused by the unknown number on his screen. He frowned and rejected it, not in the mood to talk to some stranger and tell them they had the wrong number. The second time it rang his confusion grew along with his irritation. He didn't fucking know what this person wanted but he wasn't in the goddamn mood.

So, he rejected the call again.

However, on the third try, Katsuki finally answered. He huffed and angrily pushed the blinking green button.

"What the fuck do you want?" Katsuki snapped unkindly.

The voice on the other end of the line was unbothered. "Is this Bakugou Katsuki?"

"Yes. Who the hell is asking and messing up my weekend?"

"My name is Fukuhara Yori, I'm a property manager in Biei, Hokkaidō," the gentle voice said. There was a welcoming melody carrying that usually prefaced good news. "I'm calling to discuss the estate recently handed down to you by order of inheritance from your family."

Katsuki heard that and didn't even entertain the thought. "I think there's some sort of mix up. I don't have any family that would hand me down any property, much less an estate."

"Your mother was Bakugou Mitsuki, correct?" Yori asked for clarification.

"Yeah, but she didn't own any property." Katsuki casually picked at his nails as he held the phone between his shoulder and ear. "You need to double check your records or something 'cause there's clearly been a mix up."

"Uh, I'm afraid this is not a mistake, Mr. Bakugou," Yori said once more. He could hear the perplexed stare in her voice. "Your mother's maiden name was Sakamoto, correct?"

"Yes. But I'm serious, she never owned a house or anything like that, I would know. I'm her son."

This *had* to be a mix up. They bounced around so much that there was no damn way his mom magically had a house somewhere—but—as he thought about who his mother was, he understood quickly there was a lot about her he really didn't know.

He had no clue what her life was like before him or even what she left behind.

“Your grandparents, Ren and Hina Sakamoto mentioned your name in their will in the instance that their daughter, Mitsuki, happened to have been deceased,” Yori said slowly. “They passed about six months ago. We tracked down your mother, and records show she died three years ago. Which means you’ve rightfully inherited their home.”

The words were almost spoken in a language he didn’t understand.

Grandparents? Ren and Hina?

There was no fucking way this was correct.

Katsuki’s breathing became shallow as he attempted to wrap his head around the concept. He stared around the high ceilings of his apartment. He looked up at the dazzling expensive lights he bought in an attempt to make his condo feel more welcoming. This lady had to be wrong somewhere down the line because his mother did not have a home to go to this whole time.

He had been homeless for a *year*. They had struggled so much—

“Mr. Bakugou, are you still there?” The kind woman asked him. “Are you not interested in the estate? If you want to sell it, you can. I can get you in touch with a real estate agent—”

“—No,” Katsuki quickly rejected. He sat up slowly, the world tilting with his vision. His reality turned on its side as he tried to stop his hand from fucking shaking. “Can I see the estate?”

“Of course you can, Mr. Bakugou, it’s your property now!” Yori said cheerfully. “We can get you settled up!”

Katsuki grunted in response, not trusting his own voice. He thought about what the fuck it meant to own an estate and how he never in his wildest dreams every thought of getting that far. But as his memory pressed on that locked volt of his mother’s death—Katsuki wanted to know more.

He decided he needed to see it to believe it.

☽ ☽ ☽

When Katsuki arrived in the beautiful countryside of Biei, he didn’t think such a place could exist in his reality.

It felt wrong for someone like him to gaze upon such a serene view. Farmers and smiling people leisurely passed by in their traditional clothing. In front of him were long stretches of green fields that appeared endless and right in his view was the most breathtaking sight flowers.

The flower fields were neatly sectioned off in color coded rows that welcomed any passerby. Red, orange, blue, and purple blended together like a soft rainbow. It promised nothing but

peaceful days and quiet nights.

What caught Katsuki's eye most was the row of pink flowers.

Carnations.

Beautiful, pink carnations that were lush, plenty and all around him.

Katsuki held back the strange sense that was overpowering him. He tried to ignore it but it loomed over him, following him as he walked down the dirt path. He gripped the tiny piece of paper in his hand that held the address of this so-called estate.

As he walked, he passed by many people. Some were old, some were young. Some smiled at him, and others paid him no mind.

In these people's faces he saw versions of what he thought Ren and Hina might look like. Were they blond too? Or did they have different colored hair that faded to wiry gray in their old age. He could recall asking his mother about possible family, but he had *always* been shot down. She was short in her responses, anxious even. They had no family. It was just them and it was important for Katsuki to always remember that they were alone in the world.

His mother emphasized this again and again to the point extended family never even crossed Katsuki's mind. He had been so focused on making sure they were secure he never even fucking fathom they possibly had support elsewhere.

When he arrived at the address on the paper, Katsuki could feel that unnamed feeling multiply. Sitting there was a breathtaking image. Large stone surrounded the estate with a metal gate that had golden encrusted floral designs. Standing there was a woman with kind dark brown eyes and dark hair. It was neatly pulled up into a bun and she was dressed in a gray business casual suit. Her large eyes landed on Katsuki, and her face softened into a gentle smile.

"Hello," She said. "I'm Yori, the property agent. We spoke on the phone. Are you Mr. Bakugou?"

Katsuki could only nod.

"Perfect!" Yori said with a tight-lipped smile. "I just need to see your ID and proof of a utility bill or something to confirm you are in fact the rightful inheritance to the estate. We can do all the paperwork inside."

She was polite enough to ignore his clear unease about what was happening. Katsuki fumbled a bit but took out the paperwork he was asked to bring. He handed over his ID and stared at the photo of himself strangely.

It was odd, seeing his own face and name at that moment.

She took the documents from him and double checked everything. She confirmed he was Bakugou Katsuki, and then turned on her heels to the large gates. She delicately pulled out a

set of keys from her pocket. The metallic items jingled and Katsuki wondered how many doors were inside that needed that many keys.

“I’ll let you in the property and you can take a look around,” Yori said. “If you want to keep it we can do the paperwork for it to be passed on to you. If you decide you don’t want it, we can get you set up to sell it.”

Katsuki once again could only nod.

Yori pushed open the creaky gates. They let out a rusted sound that indicated they had not moved in a while.

Once Katsuki and Yori stepped foot inside, the first thing Katsuki could see was a koi pond in the center of a garden. The beautiful fishes circled each other in the clear water and on top sat large lily pads with pink flowers. Off to the side of the koi pond was a patch of pink carnations and a delicate stone path that led to a wooden bench.

Katsuki sucked in a breath. Encasing the garden was the two floored estate, in a perfect box shape.

It was huge.

He crumbled up the paper with the address in his fingers. He was shaking—why was he shaking? He couldn’t catch his thoughts as they raced all around. He wanted to scream, yelled, say fucking something—but instead all he could feel was the heavy weight feeling of grief.

“I’ll sign the documents to keep it,” Katsuki said in a mutter.

Yori blinked. “Are you sure? You haven’t looked around.”

Katsuki shook his head slightly. “I’ll look around after I sign the paperwork.”

Yori didn’t protest. She pulled out the documents for him to sign and Katsuki glanced over the names Ren and Hina on the paper. As he signed it, he realized how odd it was to see his name in alignment with theirs. It felt disjointed almost, how connected he was to these people he never met. When he signed on the last dotted line, he asked a question he wished he never did.

“Did they know about me this whole time?” Katsuki whispered.

Yori’s face flashed with some sympathy. She sighed and tilted her head at him, and some level of candidness slipped into her.

“From what I know from just being nosy at work, yes,” Yori confirmed. “They knew you when you were a baby. They didn’t know what happened to either you or your mother, and they couldn’t locate you due to your mother secretly changing her last name. It’s why it took so long to find you to give this property.”

Katsuki didn't answer right away. When he did, he nodded like he was just hearing some stale piece of information.

"And I was found now, *because*?"

"Stroke of luck," Yori said with a shrug. She gave him a look of pity. "Our company finally got a lead on where your mother went. We were able to find the marriage certificate and confirm it was her. She had gotten married very secretly, and it was legally off a lot of records. Her marriage to Bakugou Masaru is, uh, slightly up for debate in legality."

Katsuki would have asked the details on that further had he not been so exhausted.

He nodded numbly and he gave her back her pen. She took it and muttered her goodbyes with a polite bow. Before she left, she gave him the set of endless silver keys. There were so many and Katsuki couldn't wrap his mind around how many rooms were possibly inside of this estate. He stood there frozen in time as Yori exited. She closed the gates softly and Katsuki couldn't take his eyes off the keys.

When he did, he turned his eyes to the koi fish that were circling round and round in the water. They spun like they were trapped in a time loop that kept repeating.

Katsuki exhaled a shaky breath and decided to take a look around. He pinched himself twice before reaching one of the doors. He kept having to reaffirm that this was in fact a real thing occurring and not some fucked up lucid dream of his.

As he opened the door his throat swell with the sight. It was cozy. He assumed he walked into what was the den and living area. Off to the corner was a well-used rocking chair with an unfinished knitted blanket. The knitting needles were still inside. Next to that chair was another wooden rocking chair that had a blanket and an old newspaper.

On the walls were picture frames. Inside the picture frames were people who looked like *him*.

They were all smiling in memories that he never witnessed or heard of. One photograph was of a large family gathering with many people who had blond hair and many people who did not. Some people were brunette, others had soft inky black hair. One person even had ginger hair.

He walked up closely to the picture, and it felt like looking through a window in time.

There, he could see his mother standing with the rest of her family. She was cradling a baby in red blankets in her hands. His mother's familiar eyes stared back at him, but at the same time she felt like a stranger. She wasn't smiling and it looked as though she was almost in a sorrowful pain as she cradled what he presumed to be him.

Katsuki walked deeper into the estate, and he stumbled across a great hall filled with photographs. It was so grand and polished that it felt like he was walking in a museum of memories that didn't belong to him. Memories of places, people, and things that occurred but he was never a witness to. Every picture radiated joy as he stared at them in these entrapped glass cases.

He tried to deduce who Ren was and who Hina was.

As he walked, he could progressively see the recurring image of an elder man and woman with his mother. They smiled happily and posed for photos like they lived a fabulous life. Who he decided was Hina always had a red scarf around her neck. She had beautiful blonde hair and kind gold eyes. She smiled lovingly at his mother in all the photos. Who he decided was Ren had a hard, serious look on his face. The corners of his mouth were pulled down into a scowl often in photos and he had dark black hair with blazing red eyes.

He could see pictures of his mother young. When she was a kid she was joyful and happy, collecting pink carnations. But as she grew older, a certain light in her eyes died. She grew stiffer, and meeker in the photos which was opposite of what he knew to be his mother.

Then suddenly, she disappeared from photos.

When Katsuki made it to the next room full of cozy, homey items, he struggled to believe any of this was real. He blinked rapidly, pushing back tears as he struggled to absorb it all. All the memories on the wall clearly happened, there was fucking *proof*. But staring at them like an outsider was all too painful.

When he turned the corner down another long hallway, Katsuki suddenly saw the life that could have been theirs.

He saw him and his mother living with Ren and Hina. He saw them walking these halls with them at festivals, birthdays and celebrations that he usually never bothered with. He saw the security and warmth he begged his mother for, and he saw their potential to be happy there all together. He even saw his mother dropping him off here that year instead of leaving him stranded in Tokyo. He could even dream of getting to know his grandparents, but that's all it was. A dream.

That unnamed looming sensation bloomed when Katsuki walked into an abandoned nursery.

It was small, but carefully sectioned off and across from one of the many bedrooms he had counted on his journey. It was full of toys, blankets, and there was a window that was veiled with pretty white curtains that swayed in the wind. When a breeze blew in, the curtain delicately lifted to reveal a forgotten vase full of wilted, dried-up pink carnations on the windowsill.

On one white wall was the name 'Katsuki' in neat, scarlet lettering.

He stared at the crib that looked as old as he was. The only thing in the room that wasn't coated in dust was a photograph he had never seen of him and his mother. She was holding him in a hospital bed, smiling happily. She gazed at him like he was the apple of her eye, precious and wanted.

He had never seen her look at him like that before.

Katsuki walked over to where his name was painted on the wall and stared up at it. Sitting beneath it was a white plaster of baby feet. *His* baby feet. The fossil of his life beginning and

official proof of his existence in this house.

Then that looming feeling grew stronger and stronger until it clicked. All the puzzle pieces snapped painfully into place as Katsuki came to a conclusion that scarred his soul for years to come.

He never had to live the way he did.

They had a home—they had a fucking *home*. This whole goddamn *time*.

Katsuki's body began to shake as he looked at the fossil of his past life he couldn't remember. He vibrated with sheer unchecked bitter rage. He gritted his teeth to stop himself from seething at the thought of his mother. All the memories of struggle, hunger, and painful cold were mocking him. The plaster of his baby feet seeped from white to red in his mind as he thought about how all of this could have been his.

He didn't have to be a killer. He didn't have to be a criminal. He didn't have to bury bodies. He didn't have to starve. He didn't have to be sad. He didn't have to sleep in that abandoned church. He didn't have to be so fucked up.

He didn't he didn't he didn't he fucking *didn't*—

He stared all around at the happy memories that were lined up like an exhibit of the life he never got to be a part of.

Katsuki snapped.

He angrily snatched the pure white plaster of his baby feet off the wall. He despised how it represented a clean slate of life while his hands were covered with so much red. Katsuki screamed out a violent curse as he reeled back and smashed it against the ground with all his force. He then picked up the big piece that didn't shatter enough for his satisfaction and smashed it. He did this over and over again, purposefully picking up the biggest piece and breaking it into tiny bits.

He smashed the mold until it was as broken as he was.

He made sure it reflected how unnecessarily broken he was: shattered into countless pieces that had nothing but jagged edges that threatened to cut anyone who dared touch it. Small white pieces were scattered around the nursery, decorating the ground in dangerous sharp edges that would cut through flesh. *Just like him*.

He breathed heavily through his gritted teeth and his chest heaved in anger.

Then gradually, his heaving chest melted to nothing but pain. He started sobbing, throat swelling with the feeling of being choked by the life he was never given the chance to experience.

He leaned against the wall and dryly sobbed into his closed fists. Slowly, he fluidly sank to the ground amongst the broken pieces. He pushed at his eyes, begging the tears to come but

they never did. They stayed stuck just like he was stuck in this cruel museum of potential memories that could have been his.

Katsuki’s shoulders shook as he rasped out the question that always haunted him.

“Why was I never given the chance to be fucking loved?”

Chapter End Notes

Please let me know what you think below! The Honey Moon Arc starts next chapter :)) I am writing faster now that this arc is finished. I'm super excited the next chapters coming up with everyone's favorite hitman husbands!

Chapter 14: Pianissimo

Chapter Summary

> Pianissimo (volume): Very soft

Chapter Notes

> Hello hello! Welcome to the first fluff chapter! We're officially back to everyone's favorite hitman husbands. Thanks so sticking around here at 250k words so far! I'm having a fun of fun writing this and I think this chapter finally taught me how to write fluff lol I hope you enjoy!!
>
> Thanks so much to Luna for betaing!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes



By Clannie

Chapter 14 — Pianissimo

.

.

.

Katsuki sucked in a deep breath as he stood in front of the estate. It was the dead of night, the air was heavy, and the silence was filled with anticipation. The metal gates felt taller, wider, and far more intimidating than the last time he saw them. It nearly felt like standing in front of a tombstone large enough to house all his grief.

Next to him was Izuku, leaning on his crutches. The other man was quietly inspecting the large piece of land. He was clearly surprised, not foreseeing *this* to be where Katsuki was taking him. The crickets in the background were a soft melody as Katsuki unlocked the creaky gates.

They both stepped foot inside without a word. Once in, it felt like they officially crossed into dangerous territory.

“This place is beautiful,” Izuku muttered.

Katsuki wondered if Izuku was being polite. This place was *hideous*.

The pond in the middle of the garden was clouded with debris. Ugly moss was growing all along the surface and it was obvious that it had not been taken care of for years. Off to the side and all around, weeds and long blades of overgrown grass overpowered everything. The trees were drooping. The flowers were dead. The gates they had walked through were spotted brown with rust.

Not a single thing about this place looked beautiful anymore, and that was his own fault.

Shame rattled inside of Katsuki.

“This way,” Katsuki mumbled tiredly. “Let’s get to bed.”

They walked on the gravel pathway all the way up to the front doors. Katsuki pulled them open, and a loud scrape of the rustic hinges echoed into the night. Instantly, the smell of dust reached his nose, and he could see Izuku scrunch his face slightly. A coat of grime was on the floors, reflecting the full three years of neglect. Some spider webs were nestled into the corner and the welcome rug was deeply dirty.

Izuku was nice enough not to say anything.

Katsuki led them into the part of the estate with the bedrooms. Rows of locked doors greeted them, and it was then Katsuki realized they were faced with a tad bit of awkwardness. There was no longer one bed, or one room. They didn’t have to sleep together anymore and that caused a very blunt realization to hit Katsuki: he wanted to.

Izuku slightly shifted on his feet, cutting his eye up at Katsuki.

Katsuki walked forward and unlocked the guest bedroom and the primary bedroom. Inside the guest bedroom was plain décor. Faded pink wallpaper with purple floral print. The bed

was small enough for one person to be comfortable and there was a singular wooden dresser.

The primary bedroom had a lot more to offer. Inside was a king-sized bedframe with a lace canopy falling from the top. It had a large TV inside, two wooden rocking chairs, long, full length mirror and even a nice, attached bathroom. But more importantly, it was clearly built for two.

“Uh, which one do you want?” Katsuki uncomfortably asked.

Izuku didn’t answer right away. He kept darting his eyes between Katsuki and the two choices in front of him.

“I can take the guest bedroom,” Izuku said quietly.

“Okay.” Katsuki nodded. “I’ll be next door if you need something.”

Izuku bit his lip slightly. “Alright. I’ll come knocking if I need anything.”

Katsuki didn’t address the nagging intuition of ‘*this is wrong*’ that was scratching against his skin. He set Izuku’s things down for him inside the guest bedroom and gathered the dust riddled sheets off the beds. The smell of the old linens tickled his nose as he bundled all the cloths in his arms.

“I’m going to go wash these so you can have some fresh sheets,” Katsuki said.

Izuku gave him a tiny smile. “Thank you. I’ll come with you.”

Katsuki nodded back and he quickly gathered the sheets in the main bedroom too. They walked down the winding hallways to the washing room. The windows on the edge of the wall lit the way in tiny squares of moonlight as they walked to their destination. Katsuki kept his eyes straight ahead into the darkness of the hallway while Izuku had his head turned inwards to the wall next to him.

Where the pictures once were, now were a row of small sun-bleached rectangles. These spots littered the wallpaper up and down the vast hallway. Izuku curiously ran his finger across one, studying the texture of the surface.

Izuku cocked his head. “Were there pictures here?”

“Mhm. I took them down,” Katsuki murmured.

“What were they pictures of?”

“Nothing relevant.” Katsuki didn’t turn to look at the empty reminders of his past’s ghosts. “Got any more questions for me, nosy?” He asked a little sarcastically.

“One more,” Izuku said. He stopped walking and curiously tapped one of the sun-bleached spots on the wall. “You said this was your mother’s home. Did…Did you grow up here?”

Katsuki resisted glowering.

“No. This place is my family’s—” the last word tasted like acid on his tongue, and he grimaced. “Or people who *were* my family by blood. I never knew them. I inherited this property after they all passed away, but I didn’t grow up here. My mother grew up here when she was young, I guess.”

“…But *you* never knew your family?”

“No. Wasn’t given the chance.”

Izuku studied him. “I’m sorry.”

“It’s fine, let’s not mention it. Alright?” Katsuki muttered. “It’s only me living here now and that’s probably all it’s ever going to be.”

Katsuki ignored the way Izuku gazed at him. Green eyes were too soft at that moment, all too caring and Katsuki wasn’t sure if he could stomach it. Lucky for him, Izuku was apparently good at picking up on social cues and dropped the subject.

They continued to walk down the moonlit hallways until they stumbled across the laundry room. They put the sheets in the old washer and Izuku helped him the whole time with a gentleness he quietly enjoyed.

While the sheets were going, they walked around the estate. Izuku’s doe eyes were adoring the neglected building like it was a palace while Katsuki’s were scrutinizing it. Despite being on crunches, Izuku moved swiftly like it wasn’t his first time with a broken ankle.

“What’s this room?” Izuku asked enthusiastically while pointing his crutch to a door.

“Sunroom,” Katsuki answered easily.

A warm part of his heart fluttered when Izuku hobbled to the next part of the estate and did the same thing with another room.

“And this one?”

“Pottery room.”

“What about this one?”

“Bathroom.”

“I see,” Izuku said, like it was fascinating.

Katsuki had to hold in a snicker at the bright look in Izuku’s green eyes. They walked around the corner to the next area and all the glee inside of Katsuki’s body drained. He looked at a very specific door that he hadn’t had the strength to clean out. To his horror, Izuku wobbled towards it and pointed happily at it.

“And what about this room?” Izuku asked with a grin.

The nursery. Katsuki worked his jaw, attempting to fix his tongue to say those cursed words. But every time he tried his mouth dried up and any logical explanation went away.

"…Off limits," Katsuki grumbled.

"Huh?" Izuku's smile dropped. His brows pinched together, and he wearily glanced between Katsuki and the door. "Off limits why?"

"You ask too many damn questions," Katsuki snapped a bit too harshly.

He could see Izuku recoil at the brutish tone and caught himself. It wasn't Izuku's fault, he was just always so curious like a goddamn puppy and that was more than likely due to his upbringing.

Katsuki softened his face and he shoved aside his emotions. "Off limits as in don't ever step foot in there. I mean it. I need to take that room apart and I would prefer to do it privately when I'm ready."

"…Okay. Sorry for asking," Izuku muttered. He eyed the closed door suspiciously before wobbling back up to Katsuki. "I'm sorry. I didn't mean to pry."

"No need to be sorry," Katsuki muttered. He hooked his arm around Izuku's shoulders and led him away from the nursery door. "But leave that door shut. C'mon, let's fix up your room and handicap the house for you until the bedding is finished."

Izuku nodded in understanding, but as they rounded the corner he stole one last glance behind him at the door covered in cobwebs.

☽ ☽ ☽

When they were finished getting ready for bed, they stood in the hallway between their bedrooms.

The sheets were cleaned, and everything was set to go for them to part their separate ways for the night. However, an invisible rope felt like it held Katsuki in place as he stared at Izuku next to him. Izuku was in front of his bedroom door and his hand on the handle was deathly still.

Izuku meekly turned to him and tilted his head.

"Can…Can I sleep with you?" Izuku asked nervously. "B-But only if you're okay with it. Otherwise, I don't mind sleeping in the guest room. Heh, you're probably tired of me hogging the covers."

Katsuki shook his head a little too eagerly. "No, it's fine. I was hoping you'd ask."

Izuku perked up.

Katsuki gave a nervous, lopsided smirk as his heart pounded hard against his rib cage. Without speaking another word, Izuku hobbled towards him and Katsuki opened the door to

the bedroom more than willing to let him inside. Izuku happily smiled at him as they both got under the covers in the bed. Izuku quietly thanked him and Katsuki tried his best not to let it be known how goddamn happy he was.

Izuku's warmth next to him was starting to feel routine.

Katsuki turned off the lights and they laid side by side for a long time in the dark. Izuku snuggled in closer to him, and it was then Katsuki was aware of the lack of barrier this time. He could feel Izuku's soft skin brush against him. He could feel all the tiny hills of the scars and the callouses. But most of all Katsuki could feel all the words they needed to say laying against his chest.

Before he could speak, Izuku's soft fingers intertwined with his on top of the covers.

Their matching rings gleamed in the moonlight.

They both stared at the rings, and the very real marriage hanging over their heads felt potent. He supposed they could go ahead with the divorce now since they didn't have to part ways currently.

"Can we cross that bridge when we get there?" Izuku whispered as if he could read his mind. His eyes never left their rings. "We'll discuss…the marriage but not right now. I have something else on my mind."

Avoidance. Katsuki knew this tactic well—but he was willing to avoid it too. He nodded slowly and sighed deeply. "That's fine. We can talk about it tomorrow."

Izuku smiled sadly and cusped his hand tighter.

"…I…I like you, Katsuki," Izuku whispered delicately.

Katsuki's heart stopped.

That was a sentence he never thought he would hear, and it was damn bizarre to perceive someone *liked* him. When Katsuki turned his head towards Izuku, brilliant emerald eyes were staring into him. Izuku's brows were furrowed together, and he was searching Katsuki's face for a sliver of rejection.

"Do—Do you like me too?" Izuku asked cautiously. "I-It's okay if you don't. I get it. You said you don't do all that type of stuff—"

"—I like you too," Katsuki blurted out roughly.

His chest felt instantly lighter. He breathed out easier, and he was surprised how simple it was to admit that. He liked Izuku. He liked him *a lot* if he was being honest with himself.

Izuku then let out a tiny breath of relief and smiled sadly at him.

"Th-That makes me happy to hear," Izuku chuckled. "I thought for a second you were, uh, going to say you liked me but not like *that*."

“You think it’d ask you to come live with me for a couple of months if I didn’t like you in that way?” Katsuki smirked. “Yeah, I wanted to make sure you’re taken care of and healed, but I’ll admit there’s…other motives. Selfish ones.” He gripped Izuku’s hand back tightly. “Is that bad?”

“No. I was selfish for coming here too.” Izuku’s eyes skirted off to the side. “I-I wanted more time with you and this feels—*good*. I’m not decent at talking about myself or my feelings, but I feel like I’m supposed to be here with you.”

Katsuki’s mind cruelly prompted him about Izuku’s past.

“You—” Katsuki licked his lips. “I feel like you’re supposed to be here too.”

The sadness in Izuku’s eyes grew bluer. Katsuki worked his jaw as he thought about Tokyo, Moore, and how he had left Izuku there.

Izuku hesitantly smiled at him when the tenseness in Katsuki grew. “You know, I had a crush on you when we were kids.” A change of subject that Katsuki decided to take.

He let out a sharp laugh. “Hah. I figured.”

“What gave it away?” Izuku laughed lightly too.

“Possibly the dumb fake marriage and giving each other kisses every day.”

“To be fair, the fake marriage was *your* idea.” Izuku smiled radiantly and rested his chin against Katsuki’s chest. “Does this mean you had a crush on me too?”

“I didn’t realize it, but yeah, I liked you a lot,” Katsuki whispered. He traced a finger up and down Izuku’s spine as the other man laid on top of him comfortably. “I couldn’t stop thinking about you even if I tried. Then *unfortunately* I think I was crushing on you as *Deku* too over the years.”

“I was, uh, crushing on you too—over the years,” Izuku shyly confessed. “I looked forward to seeing the cranky guy with bad aim sometimes.”

Katsuki scoffed. “Bad aim? I have excellent fucking aim.”

“Sure you do.” Izuku chuckled. “But, I would secretly hope to run into you, even though it would mean I missed my mark.”

Katsuki raised a brow. “Really?”

“I thought it was obvious,” Izuku said. “I let you go every single time.”

Maybe he was more oblivious than he thought.

As they laid side by side, smiling at each other, Katsuki wondered if what he was feeling was normal when someone liked another person. He felt warm, and strangely pliant under the weight of Izuku. He could feel his heart hammer in rhythm with Izuku’s and for once he felt

lulled into a peace. While Izuku talked about all the things they could do together, Katsuki let the notion of liking Izuku plant in his heart.

When Izuku brushed his hair behind his ear, he wanted him to touch him again. When Izuku scrunched his nose while laughing, he wanted to make him giggle more. When Izuku snuggled into his side, Katsuki held him back as soft as he could imitate to make him feel safe.

Katsuki drifted off to sleep that night listening to the sound of Izuku's voice telling him some story.

☽ ☽ ☽

The following morning Katsuki's whole body felt like it had finally shifted out of his survival instincts. His limbs felt heavier, his mind was calm and all around he could hear the chirps of the birds from outside the window.

He sat up that morning with a light yawn and an arm slung around his waist. Katsuki turned his eyes to see Izuku snoring lightly, head tucked into his side, fully asleep. His dark curls were messy, all over the place and his body was plastered against his.

Warm was Katsuki's first thought. The second was how peaceful Izuku seemed laying there. His last thought was acknowledging the painful rumble in his stomach that fully woke him up. His mind wandered to food then he was hit with the revelation that they didn't *have* any food.

Judging by how deep Izuku was sleeping, Katsuki figured he could sneak out and maybe have breakfast ready by the time the nerd woke up.

Katsuki attempted to carefully lift Izuku's arm but in return he earned a groggy protest. Izuku slightly pouted and he latched on harder with a sleepy mumble.

"*No*," Izuku muttered in his sleep. "Kacchan, go back to sleep."

Kacchan.

Katsuki's heart skipped at the nickname, it touched him like a warm caress in an unsuspecting way.

He thought Okinawa would be the last place he'd hear that, and before that Tokyo. But now he supposed he was going to hear it more frequently. Izuku really was here with him, and he still felt like this was all some surreal dream.

Katsuki hesitantly laid back down, suddenly feeling like he was in unfamiliar territory. Izuku cuddled in closer to him and Katsuki cradled his arms around Izuku as well. He buried his nose into the top of soft green hair and closed his eyes again.

He experimentally ran his hand through Izuku's curls. Izuku hummed happily.

☽ ☽ ☽

When they finally decided to get up, Katsuki felt refreshed.

The air entering his lungs was crisp, clean in a way only the countryside could be. The smell of grass and flowers filled the room naturally and his body felt like it had been released of some looming spirit gripping his bones. The extra gravity of anxiety that kept him on edge had dissipated into nothing.

They leisurely got out of bed, showered, and Katsuki helped Izuku get dressed into his clothes with extra care. Because of his wrist and ankle, Izuku still struggled a bit with handling things. During the entire routine to get out of the bedroom, Izuku shyly looked towards him in a silent plea for help.

Katsuki took the hint and helped Izuku out of his pajamas and into his day clothes. This was the first time Izuku wasn't in his ugly pink shirts. Instead, he was sporting a green plaid button down and blue jean shorts.

The other man was blushing the entire time he was undressed, and Katsuki tried his best not to smirk at Izuku's shyness. It was undeniably cute. He drank in the sight of Izuku lifting his hips, and he adored the cutesy panties Izuku had. He noted happily that it seemed to be all the underwear Izuku packed. Part of Katsuki wanted to tease Izuku further when he could sense some level of sexual tension.

However, when he bumped Izuku's ankle by accident his face dropped at the sound of the other man hissing in discomfort. Katsuki quickly backed off and told himself and his dick to calm down until Izuku wasn't in goddamn pain.

After that, Katsuki dressed in his usual black shirt and long black pants. Izuku poked some comment about his outfits still always being darkly colored, but Katsuki simply shrugged.

With breakfast on the mind, the pair walked into the kitchen with Izuku on his crutches and Katsuki holding his waist. When he helped Izuku over to the open window across the way, Katsuki decided to check at his phone—and he wished he hadn't.

Ten missed calls from Aizawa.

"Shit," Katsuki mumbled while scratching at the back of his head. "I need to make a call."

"Go ahead," Izuku said offhandedly. "I'll admire your garden in the meantime."

Izuku graced him with a smile that diminished any anxiety inside of him. Katsuki smiled back and his eyes darted between Izuku and the name on his phone.

If only his mother could see him now—or worse, fucking *Aizawa*. He could practically hear the lecture: "What the fuck do you mean you're helping heal the green menace?"

How did he even begin to explain what Izuku was to him? Lost childhood friend? Accidental husband? Which could be a better fucking description? Aizawa probably wouldn't even care. He'd take one look at Izuku and probably slap the shit out of Katsuki—*again*.

This was definitely something Aizawa could *never* find out about.

Because Katsuki couldn't kill Izuku now. Not even if he wanted to.

Katsuki walked backwards and around the corner a bit, out of ear shot so Izuku couldn't hear him. He reluctantly pressed dial on Aizawa's number and *immediately* the man picked up.

"Bakugou, I've been trying to call you all morning," Aizawa tiredly said on the other line. "You still need to close out and give me your company property. You said you would reconnect with me when you're settled in."

"I know, I know," Katsuki mumbled.

He peaked around the corner to see Izuku leaning against the windowsill. The other man was curiously touching the fabric of the white curtains like it was surreal to him. Izuku smiled handsomely in the sunlight.

"I'm—" Katsuki licked his lips. "I'm still getting stuff set up here before I come to close out, alright? I'll be down there once everything is settled in."

He watched as Izuku opened the window and leaned out of it slightly. The wind blew through his hair, and he closed his eyes as the breeze swept across his face.

Elegant, Katsuki thought.

"…Okay," Aizawa eventually said, having a contemplative moment of silence. "I do have to ask, is everything alright? I saw the news report of Okinawa and it seemed….like a lot. Way more than what was intended for this assignment. Nothing out of the ordinary happened, did it?"

"No," Katsuki quickly lied. "I had a bit of difficulty getting close to Moore is all. Shit got bloody."

"You sure?" Aizawa pushed. "Moore's headquarters was more than bloody to say the least. It's not exactly your style of execution. Well. That's not true—how do I say this? You haven't had any extra casualties like that since you were *twenty*, Bakugou. You usually get in and out ever since Mitsuki passed. Are you feeling okay, *emotionally*? The slit throat for Koizumi and knife to the heart for Moore felt a bit personal."

Izuku turned at that moment and caught his eye from across the way. He waved at Katsuki bashfully with a timid smile. Fuck. He was *really* cute.

"Yeah, I'm fine, old man," Katsuki brushed off, entirely distracted. "My emotions are in check. I'll talk to you later and see you soon. Don't stress about me."

"Alright, if you say so. If you don't come soon I'm going to have to send someone to come check in on you."

"Yeah. Whatever. Bye." Katsuki mumbled and clicked the phone off.

He couldn't give two shits about what Aizawa was saying about his emotions when there was finally a cute guy who *liked* him in his fucking house. He then noticed how hard his heart

was hammering just from Izuku waving at him.

He readily walked over to Izuku who was using the ledge of the dusty window for support. He watched, slightly mesmerized by how the wind touched Izuku. His face was flush, and his curls were sweeping with the breeze like some elegant work of breathing, living art. It all made Katsuki want to be closer to him.

So, he shuffled in, trying to play it as casual as possible.

Katsuki leaned against the windowsill, brushing their shoulders subtly on purpose. Izuku's cheeks colored a pretty pink and it made Katsuki smirk. He leaned in closer to Izuku, snaking his arm around his waist and pulled him in closely. They smiled shyly at each other while they soaked up the warm sun.

Katsuki returned his gaze forward, and he studied the garden outside. He resisted frowning as he noted all the various overgrown plants. He would have to straighten all this up and get it sorted out if he was going to live here seriously.

As Katsuki started imagining all the different ways he could rearrange the yard, he missed Izuku studying the way the sun fell on his face. The other man beamed at him fondly.

"What was that call about?" Izuku questioned.

"Nothing important, just my supervisor," Katsuki said nonchalantly. "I have to close out with him soon and get my official retirement settled up. I'll do that soon when we're all good up here."

"That sounds nice." Izuku smiled at Katsuki. "You're officially retired then."

"I am." Katsuki nodded.

The trees in his yard swayed with the strong winds like they were made of flimsy material. The pond rippled with tiny folds to some unheard metronome in his mind. Even the overgrown blades of grass looked like they had a story to tell. To Katsuki, it all felt so soft and serene. He hoped he could fit in.

Katsuki exhaled roughly and slouched a bit.

"Are you okay?" Izuku asked, eying him up and down. He turned his body inwards to him.

"Yeah," Katsuki muttered. He gripped Izuku's waist a little tighter. "I think the concept of retirement is weird. That's all."

"How come?"

Katsuki shrugged, unsure he wanted to elaborate.

Izuku tilted his head to the side. "…You're not used to resting. Are you?"

"No, I guess I'm not." Katsuki pressed his lips in a thin line.

Izuku gradually inched his hand towards Katsuki's that was perched on the windowsill. Carefully, Izuku laid his hand on top of Katsuki's. Warmth spread from the tip of his fingers down to his spine. Katsuki glanced at where they were touching, wondering if that type of feeling was normal. But he didn't have time to consider the sensation of comfort as Izuku's fingers intertwined with his.

He once again looked at the wedding ring on Izuku's finger glimmering so brightly.

"Let's get you used to resting," Izuku said above a whisper. "You deserve to rest. What's the first thing you want to do in your retirement?"

"Probably grocery shop so we don't starve," Katsuki said. "Can't relax if we've got empty stomachs."

Izuku laughed lightly and leaned into him all the way. He gripped Katsuki's hand harder as he grinned wide.

"Good point! Let's do that first then. Kacc—Katsuki."

Katsuki's heart skipped a beat, and he could tell Izuku's did too.

They stared at each other for a moment before they both broke out in candy-colored blushes. Izuku's face deepened to a dark red and his grip on Katsuki loosened a bit. He was about to pull away, but Katsuki quickly caught it and gripped his hand back and leaned in.

"You can call me Kacchan if you want," Katsuki said fluidly.

His heart hammered as he got close to Izuku's face. He could see all those different colored freckles, and this time he adored them a little differently. Izuku's pretty green eyes were unsure, but hopeful.

"Really?" Izuku asked softly, breath brushing against his lips. "You said you hated pet names a while ago."

"Well." Katsuki cleared his throat as he blushed. "Kacchan is fine. It's different."

"Okay." Izuku smiled. "Kacchan it is."

He looked down at that wedding ring once more, and so did Izuku. Neither of them spoke a word but the awkwardness trickled in like slow poison. He knew they should talk about it. Izuku knew they should talk about it. But neither of them mentioned it.

Katsuki decided to simply appreciate how Izuku's hand fit in his. That was enough for him at the moment, and it seemed like it was enough for Izuku too. They had until Izuku's ankle healed to work all that out, and like Izuku said: they would cross that bridge when they got there.

☽ ☽ ☽

When they arrived at the grocery store, Katsuki noted Izuku's slight fatigue. The other man hadn't complained at all about his crutches, and he was skilled on them, but the way he hobbled still gave Katsuki pause.

"Are you tired?" Katsuki asked when Izuku made a pained face.

"Huh?" Izuku said. He perked up a bit, and quickly covered up that tiny bit of lethargy he was showing. "Oh, no! I'm alright."

Katsuki raised a brow. "It's alright if you're not. I thought we were *resting*, remember?"

Izuku then looked like he got caught red handed. He sheepishly smiled. "You got me. I guess you're not the only one who is bad at resting."

"Hold still for a second."

Katsuki stepped forward and wrapped his arm around Izuku's waist and pulled him close. He ignored the soft protest Izuku gave and the way the other man blushed at the close contact. Swiftly, Katsuki gathered up the crutches and placed them down on the ground and lifted Izuku in his arms. He walked over to where the carts were and gently placed Izuku inside of one, mindful of his leg. He returned to gather the crutches and placed them on the bottom of the cart.

Izuku was redder than a tomato.

"Th-This doesn't look ridiculous?" Izuku whispered, embarrassed. He eyed the people who were passing by, surveying them with strange glances.

"Who gives a damn?" Katsuki shot back. He grinned cockily and started pushing the cart. "As long as you're comfortable that's all that matters. If someone says something to us, I'll cuss them out."

Izuku laughed shyly. He meekly fiddled with the wedding band on his finger while glancing at Katsuki.

☽ ☽ ☽

Grocery shopping with Izuku was surprisingly relaxing.

Normally he did this by himself, playing a guessing game of what food would give him maximum output of health so he could operate well enough. But it was strangely nice to have someone do it with him, and also he wasn't shopping just because he needed fuel to kill.

Katsuki pushed the cart along, putting food in the cart either around or on top of Izuku, who was more than happy to hold on to some stuff. The other man was grinning wide, pointing at different foods he wanted to try and Katsuki was far more eager to buy them for Izuku than he wanted to admit.

When they made it to the fresh vegetables, Katsuki scanned over everything in the aisle. He scrutinized which one would be better as he picked up a stock of greens and inspected it

closely. He didn't want to accidentally get some bad pick of the lot and unintentionally make Izuku sick. He eyed Izuku who was happily swinging his good leg over the lip of the cart as he hummed lightly to himself.

His stomach twisted a bit seeing such a simple sight.

Izuku waved at him and tilted his head.

Blush unwillingly rushed to Katsuki's face. *Fuck*. This was going to be a thing now, he realized, and he was goddamn mortified. All Izuku had to do was act cute and his heart was a mess. He snapped his head away, trying to calm his heart down.

All he did was look at you. Stop acting so goddamn sprung, Katsuki reprimanded himself. He returned his attention back to the food in his hands. He turned it over carefully, seeing no rot or odd brownish spots and nodded in approval. When Katsuki bagged the stock of greens he placed them over in the cart on Izuku's lap who had a smile on his lips.

Katsuki did this over and over again, making sure to pick the best food. He knocked on the watermelon in a way Aizawa had shown him when he was younger, and then made sure to carefully inspect each egg for zero cracks.

They went through the store, picking up various juices and cuts of meat. About halfway through the adventure, Izuku was stacked up to his chest happily with food in the cart. He was smiling happily at Katsuki the whole time with an amused grin and asked Izuku what foods he would prefer and Izuku, like some kid in a candy store, eagerly said all the bad shit.

"Izuku, you can't just fucking eat junk food," Katsuki muttered when Izuku pointed to the nth goddamn bag of skittles. "You already have Hershey Kisses, Snickers, and Cheeto Puffs. Pick something else."

"But I've never had Junk Food before," Izuku said quietly while holding the copious amount of candy against his chest. "Please, Kacchan?"

Izuku looked up at him, big green doe eyes in full force.

Damnit.

Katsuki scowled and snatched the skittles off the shelf. He tossed them in the cart on top of Izuku and resisted smiling at the tiny 'yay' Izuku exclaimed. Katsuki shook his head and ruffled Izuku's hair playfully.

"When you get a million cavities, remember you only have yourself to blame," Katsuki lectured, but smirked as he said it.

Izuku leaned his head back against the end of the cart to look up at him. "I'll take full responsibility!"

Katsuki started pushing the cart through the store again, leaning down as he did it. He wondered how they looked to the other people who were eyeing them. They were probably a

sight: two grown men with a cart full of healthy food and way more junk food, snickering to themselves as they talked about the random combinations of cuisine they could make.

When they were waiting in line to check out, Izuku remained peeking up at him from below. Katsuki looked down at him once, flexing his brows in acknowledgement but as they stayed in line, Izuku's eyes barely moved. He was gazing at him softly like he was some rare vision.

"And what are you looking at, nerd?" Katsuki teased with a smirk.

"Just you," Izuku answered simply.

Katsuki chuckled and leaned down. He pushed Izuku's bangs back and placed a small kiss on his forehead.

☽ ☽ ☽

They arrived back at the estate and Katsuki put all the groceries away as Izuku watched.

He made breakfast quietly, listening to the radio and heard some reports about the slaughter in Okinawa. He only caught a few bits and pieces through the wavering static. Most of it was about witness reports and the uncovering of the human trafficking that was taking place. Moore's crimes were officially getting aired out and it was pulling strings in places that were in shadows.

After Katsuki finished cooking two full plates of delicious food, he turned off the radio. He decided to ignore reality for a moment when the station started describing exactly how the human cages looked. Izuku appeared thankful for the gesture and Katsuki smiled at him as he sat down at the table.

They ate while chatting casually. Izuku was eager to ask him questions about all the things he wanted to do in his retirement.

"What type of things were you hoping to do, Kacchan?" Izuku asked once he finished his breakfast.

"I guess normal people shit, like landscaping," Katsuki said flatly. He poked a bit at the vegetables on his plate with a shrug. "I want to fix up the garden outside to look decent and get some home-grown food going in the back since I have enough land for it."

"That sounds perfect," Izuku happily replied. "What else?"

Katsuki froze. What else? He searched the vastness of his mind, only for it to come up empty. He could only see tiny visions of pink carnations littered in the corners of his void. What he once thought would be his future hasn't been there in five years—and he hadn't stayed still long enough to consider *what else.*

"I…I guess that's all I got," Katsuki admitted sadly. "Maybe get some type of small job to keep me from getting lazy."

Izuku's happy face slowly fell. "That's it? Get a job?"

“I guess?” Katsuki grimaced. “What else is there to do?”

“What about stuff you always wanted to do?” Izuku curiously asked. “Like learning how to play guitar, or some other instrument. Something like a bucket list! Don’t you have one?”

“No,” Katsuki scoffed. “When would I have time to make a bucket list? Do *you* have one?”

Izuku shyly averted his eyes. “Yeah. I-I have it written in the back of the book I always carry.”

Katsuki raised an eyebrow at that. “Really?”

“Yeah, but this isn’t about me—”

Katsuki didn’t wait too long before standing up with a knowing smirk. “It’s about you now.”

“Wh-What? No!” Izuku’s eyes went wide with embarrassment, and he tried to get up to stop Katsuki.

However, Katsuki was quicker and sadistic. Without thinking twice, Katsuki snatched the crutches out of Izuku’s reach before he could hobble up and stop him. Green eyes stretched wide and Izuku’s mouth dropped down in disbelief.

Katsuki walked into the bedroom and dug into Izuku’s suitcase, ignoring the yelling of several profane protests in the background. He moved aside Izuku’s colorful underwear collection, sweaters and clothes to find that tiny, tattered book.

He opened it, reading that first line once again.

“We are not the ugly parts of ourselves.”

It struck a chord just like last time.

Katsuki stared at it for a moment, as though the words were floating off the page.

The sentiment rang differently knowing all he knew about Izuku now—especially all those tally marks that were inside of the first page. He ran his fingers along them, feeling the indents on some of the tally marks and the lack of indents on others. The way Izuku probably dug his pen into the page on a couple of these first ones told a story he didn’t dare to ask. The potent pain these were written with leapt through time.

It was then that Katsuki noted the fresh tally marks with clean ink. Eleven. He tilted his head to the side.

Moore’s headquarters. Izuku was counting.

Katsuki wondered if Izuku always counted when he killed. Then Katsuki wondered what his own number would be if he ever bothered to do such a thing. Suddenly, knowing Izuku’s bucket list for life being in the same book as his sins made the tiny object feel a lot heavier than what it was. Katsuki carefully stood back up and strolled back into the kitchen. He

thumbed through all the pages, noting some underlined words before flipping all the way to the back.

He stopped short in front of the pouting Izuku. The other man was narrowing his eyes at him.

“Glaring isn’t going to help anything,” Katsuki announced casually as he skimmed over the list. “I find you sexy when you’re annoyed, so you’re accomplishing nothing besides turning me on a little.”

Izuku’s blush deepened, and he shyly toyed with his wedding ring.

“Have a picnic?” Katsuki read curiously. He looked between Izuku and the words that were written in sloppy penmanship. “Pottery. Have a birthday party. Baking. Dance to the titanic song.” The latter two were crossed off and Katsuki’s heart flipped. “Go to a festival. Make flower crowns. Play violin for an audience. Learn more violin music. Take a walk in the park. Hiking. Spend time at a mall?”

Katsuki’s stomach turned. These were such simple things—but one stood out like it was written in red to him.

Have a birthday party.

He recalled Tokyo and remembered how young Izuku always said he never celebrated his birthday.

Izuku stammered and hung his head. “I-I know it’s a silly list, Kacchan. I-I wrote it one day when I learned what b-bucket lists are from someone. Y-You don’t have to make fun of me —”

“—Let’s do these.”

Izuku snapped his head up in surprise. “Wh-What?”

“I’ve never given myself too much thought to be honest, Izuku,” Katsuki admitted earnestly. “I had no real clue what I was going to do in retirement. I only knew I was going to come to this godforsaken estate, fix it up, and I was going to play it by ear. But—let’s do this list of yours. I think it can be fun.”

Let me make up for lost time, Katsuki privately thought.

The light caught Izuku’s eye in an enchanting way. The hope inside of them now was bright, radiant even.

“Really, Kacchan?” Izuku whispered and it pulled directly on his heart.

“Yeah.” Katsuki smirked as his heart hammered heavily. “We can do anything you want.”

Izuku smiled at him like he never thought he would hear those words.

☽ ☽ ☽

The next two weeks were spent doing tiny things, like cleaning up the estate in the morning and playing movies at night.

During the night, they always watched old black and white movies on the television. Katsuki liked the way the actors were over-expressive and the monologues they did. It was corny, but enjoyable. A lot of romance aspects were always intertwined with these movies, which Izuku ate up like he was in heaven. Every single touch, longing look, or romantic quip on screen caused Izuku to suck in a breath or clutch the bed sheets slightly tighter.

He really did love this stuff, Katsuki realized.

Katsuki made a note to always watch romantic movies with Izuku because it usually resulted in cuddles sessions as they watched it together. They fell asleep like that every night, wrapped in each other's arms and embraced tightly.

During the mornings after that, Katsuki focused all his energy on cleaning.

He was determined to get rid of the dust, fix up the tattered appliances, and finally make the garden into something worth viewing. As he did this, Izuku was always nearby, reading his worn-down book with a giddy smile and blush on his face. Katsuki was beginning to get curious about what the fuck the nerd was actually reading whenever Izuku would grow quiet and squirm slightly.

Periodically, Izuku would look over at him and they would make eye contact. That beautiful, freckled face would gaze at him with a smile.

Soft. Delicate. *Pretty*. These words came to mind when Katsuki saw Izuku stretched out on the wooden porch in his green jinbei. He seemed so different now that he was away from bloodshed and violence. This was the same man who admitted to poisoning himself in small doses so he could be immune—yet here he was: looking so unsuspectingly sweet.

Was this who Izuku was once all that was stripped away? Just a pretty, adorable nerd.

There were unspoken words with the way Izuku regarded him these two weeks. Neither one of them discussed the divorce, and neither one of them took off those damned rings. They simply ignored it. Katsuki considered bringing up the divorce, but every time he tried he would catch Izuku privately gazing at the ruby gem on his finger.

That deep look of longing stunted Katsuki.

Then that same look would be given to *him*. He even couldn't take off his ring if he wanted to. Not when Izuku's eyes were on him like that. Katsuki could've sworn that his life was worth something for once whenever Izuku's eyes lit up like the emerald gem on his finger.

☽ ☽ ☽

Slowly but surely, the estate felt like it was more of a home.

The dust was swept away. Music played from speakers. Izuku's tiny chuckles could always be heard around the various corners of the home. Even the garden outside was pruned until it was presentable. The lush trees were growing with reddish leaves and the lily pads had tiny pink blossoms on top of them in the pond. The estate finally felt like it was alive and breathing and not a left over corpse.

When Katsuki finished cleaning the living room, he stopped vacuuming for a moment to admire the way it looked. It was spotless, the fireplace was going, and the furniture was rearranged with the help of Izuku telling him what might look better.

Overall, it was cozier and warmer. But Katsuki was unsure if that was because of the work that he had done.

"This is much better, isn't it?" Izuku asked happily.

Izuku was stretched out on the couch that day with a fuzzy blanket, smiling at him without a care in the world. If Katsuki didn't know any better, he looked as if he had lived here for years. Katsuki leaned against the vacuum for a moment. He study the way Izuku's messy curls looked nice against the light color of the couch.

"Yeah, much better," Katsuki said with a lopsided smirk. "Officially evicted all the spiders so we finally get some real privacy."

Katsuki wished he would have taken a video of the way Izuku laughed.

Shortly after that moment, Katsuki found himself purchasing a digital camera and taking all the videos and photos of Izuku he could. He took photos of Izuku in the garden. Photos of him on the porch. Videos of him leaning against the window and smiling over his shoulder at him. There were even photos of him while he was reading his book, eyes not even bothering looking at him.

Those were Katsuki's favorite.

Katsuki would sometimes stare at those videos and photos in moments of silence.

He filled the stillness in his life with trying to make sure Izuku was real, and that someone as seemingly nice as Izuku was here with him—smiling at him. *Liking* him. There was such a pureness in his eyes that Katsuki always saw other people stare at their loved ones with. He had never seen such a gaze on him. Not even from his own mother and he was now too old to remember if his father ever gazed at him like that.

As they finished cleaning the estate, it came down to the final room: the nursery.

Katsuki had tried to open it but found himself frozen whenever he touched the door handle. It felt icy underneath his touch. He flat out started avoiding it. Hell, he even pretended like it didn't exist when it felt like stones were settling in the bottom of his body from the thought of confronting what that room represented.

He cleaned everywhere but the nursery, and it didn't take too long for Izuku to apparently see that.

One day, Katsuki thought he was about to have a heart attack. He watched Izuku ignorantly hobble over to that damn door and point to it with an unknowing happy smile.

"Oh, Kacchan!" Izuku called. "You missed cleaning this room—"

"—No." Katsuki quickly snapped. His tone was harsher than he intended for it to be, and he could see Izuku's smile drop within the second. Katsuki cleared his throat and shook his head. "I'll get to it eventually."

"But you're already in the moment, you should clean it with the rest of the house."

"I said no, Izuku," Katsuki hissed sternly. "I mean it. Don't go in there and stop asking questions about it."

He narrowed his eyes to give emphasis and this time Izuku coiled away from the room.

They continued about their days and Katsuki buried the thought of the nursery.

However, while he did that, he missed the weary, yet curious stare Izuku gave to the door.

☽ ☽ ☽

After the entire house was spotless, it suddenly felt closer to the home Katsuki wanted it to be. Everything was polished to the brim and the garden was finally flourishing. The smell of food was always in the air and the bedroom was finally feeling more like a bedroom he would own.

Izuku was with him every step of the way, and it was a type of peaceful companionship Katsuki never exactly experienced. Izuku didn't want anything from him. Didn't expect anything from him. Nor did he ever truly ask for much. The other man stuck by his side with a bright grin and was always curious about his life and him.

"If you could travel anywhere in the world, where would you go, Kacchan?"

"I think I would just travel Japan all around," Katsuki said honestly. "I feel like I've traveled a lot around Japan, but not for the right reason. So, I want to see what our home country has to offer without being guided by some sort of assignment."

"That's a lovely idea actually," Izuku muttered. He tapped his finger against his lip. "I think we should plan for a mini trip then. Have you ever been to Nara?"

"The place with the deer? No, but I always wanted to."

"Let's do it!"

Izuku grinned wide and it was then that Katsuki noticed Izuku had one slightly crooked tooth. Cute.

Katsuki tilted his head at the other man who eagerly wrote down ‘Visit Nara, Japan’ in the back of his book. His tongue stuck out unknowingly and as he did this. It made Katsuki subconsciously smile.

“There.” Izuku announced. He held up the list for Katsuki to see. “Something else for us to do for you.”

The corners of Katsuki’s mouth twitched upwards into a smirk. “Perfect.”

For the first time in a while, he felt heard.

☽ ☽ ☽

They began doing the things on Izuku’s list shortly after that day.

The first activity they did was a walk in the park.

It wasn’t so much a walk however due to Izuku’s crutches. Katsuki found an easy way to improvise though when he insisted Izuku climb on his back, and they did a piggyback ride around the area of the countryside. Izuku’s body was warm and flushed against his, giggling the entire time in his ear. Izuku’s arms stayed wrapped around his shoulders as they went up and down the vast fields of Biei.

“Thank you for carrying me,” Izuku whispered directly into his ear. His breath was warm and tickled him slightly. Katsuki could feel the heat trickle down his nape as he hooked Izuku’s legs around him tighter.

“It’s not a problem at all,” Katsuki muttered back, trying to hide his blush.

But he knew he was unsuccessful in hiding the pinkness of his face when Izuku giggled again and laid a soft kiss on his nape. Then Izuku curled into him tighter and buried his face directly into the side of his neck.

“I love the way you smell,” Izuku mumbled against his skin. “Have I ever told you that?”

“No,” Katsuki chuckled as they walked past a lake. He looked at the way the sun speckles danced across the blue waves. “What do I smell like?”

“Like fresh cinnamon,” Izuku said.

Katsuki hummed at that thought. He never thought about how he smelled before.

☽ ☽ ☽

Next was the pottery session.

It was fucking messier than Katsuki would have liked, and he should have known a little shit like Izuku would be someone to throw clay at him. They stayed inside for a couple of days on and off making pottery. Izuku was beyond delighted to do it and the little nerd made a tiny heart with their initials inside of it.

Katsuki on the other hand made a vase in the shape of Izuku's ass.

Izuku's mouth dropped open when he realized what it was and attempted to destroy it. But Katsuki was quicker, and he wasn't the one on crutches.

He chuckled defiantly as he placed it on the tallest shelf he knew Izuku could never reach. He allowed it to dry and eventually used it as a centerpiece in the living room. He put a load of flowers inside of it and it was the most beautiful vase Katsuki had ever seen.

He gave it a happy slap every morning before breakfast after that. Izuku's face turned beet red in embarrassment every single time. But Katsuki kissed Izuku on the cheek in victory to smooth it out.

They hung Izuku's heart with their initials above their bed.

☽ ☽ ☽

The next week, Katsuki insisted they finally have a picnic.

In the movie they watched the previous night, the couple did the same thing. Like some romantic getaway shit. But despite the lovey dovey aspect of it, he secretly enjoyed the way the movie couple looked: relaxed out in the open in the field of flowers. He could easily envision himself with Izuku in that same way.

When they made it out into the large field, Katsuki never had thought about what a picnic would be like, but it was relaxing. Or maybe spending time with Izuku away from everything was relaxing. He couldn't exactly tell which one it was, but he was alright with it being the latter when Izuku gave him a fond smile.

They had found a spot under some tree with a soft blanket and pillows and set up for the day. Izuku insisted they do the flower crowns this day too. Katsuki thought it would be a good idea, and they spent the afternoon with their picnic food trying to intertwine flowers together.

"How do you make these dumb crowns?" Katsuki muttered as he picked up another flower from the pile he had plucked.

He tried to twist the stems together and realized they were failing. Both of them.

"Just try to read the instructions again," Izuku urged. His tongue stuck out slightly in concentration.

The nerd was approaching this very differently than he was. Izuku had printed out some instructions on paper from the old, obsolete printer that was in the office space at the estate. The ink was splotchy and slightly faded but it got the job done.

Katsuki on the other hand, figured he would wing it. He found some twigs, purple flowers and dandelions and figured he could put something together. Eventually, they both figured it out and it didn't take long for Izuku to make a crown of vibrant yellow dandelions for him.

Katsuki ventured out to find more flowers for Izuku's crown and plucked various colors of blue, green, purple, and pink to weave into Izuku's. He placed it softly on Izuku's head of silky curls.

Katsuki smiled at the way the flowers complimented Izuku's freckles. He was so elegant like this, even more so than he was back at the headquarters. This Izuku was gentle and caring. Soft spoken and lovely in every sense of the word. Katsuki decided he liked all the sides of Izuku: the dangerous side and the gentle one. He especially liked how Izuku's pretty eyes shyly gazed down to their checkered blanket. But he liked it even more when Izuku tucked a tiny stray curl of hair behind his ear. So fucking *cute*.

"Does it look okay on me?" Izuku asked quietly.

"More than okay. You look beautiful," Katsuki said quietly.

Izuku blushed with the widest grin. "You look nice too."

Katsuki could feel his face heat up slightly. He chuckled quietly and rubbed his burning nape. "Thanks, nerd."

The afternoon carried on with them finishing the rest of the picnic and watching the clouds above.

They laid down side by side on the soft blanket and Katsuki worked up the courage to take Izuku's hand in his. He handled it with both of his own, cusping it and gently tracing the hills of his knuckles. The wind blew in and made the sky above them a makeshift story. They pointed out different shapes they saw in the large, fluffy clouds. Izuku saw a lot of animals: elephants, rabbits, and puppies. Katsuki laughed as Izuku described it looked like a deer running from a duck in the sky.

Katsuki on the other hand could see two boys playing tag. He wondered if holding Izuku's hand was influencing him, but he told Izuku what he saw. When he studied it closer, he could see them happy and holding hands throughout the story line and his heart felt lighter as he stared up at the sky.

Izuku's thumb softly traced circles along his skin.

Then one cloud came along, and to Katsuki it looked like a violin.

He nervously licked his lips, wondering how to be vulnerable. He felt safe here, in the open field with Izuku under the clouds and sun.

"I…I always wanted to make classical music," Katsuki confessed while looking up at the clouds. Izuku shifted to stare at him curiously, but Katsuki kept his eyes trained up towards the bright blue sky. "It's always something I kept pushing to the side all my life for more important things. But I've always had an interest in composing."

"Is it because of that old violinist we knew?" Izuku asked curiously.

Katsuki nodded. "I'm going to take a wild guess that's why you like to play violin as well."

“We’re two nerds cut from the same cloth I think.” Izuku laughed, as light as air. “Have you looked into classical music lessons? That could be a good step into your new life.”

Katsuki shrugged, not thinking much about it. “Ah, no. I suppose I could. I never thought about it.”

They enjoyed the rest of the evening and when the sky turned from calming blue to dusk orange, Katsuki got up and started gathering their things. He neatly tucked away their blanket and left over food with care. When they were all set he bent down and gave Izuku a piggy back ride. They walked together, talking about the different kinds of flowers they saw along the way all the way back to the estate.

When they got settled in bed for the night, Izuku was casually on his phone searching for something. Katsuki paid no mind to it, for once actually into the black and white movie that was on television. It was called Casablanca or something close to that. It was really fucking good, and he was enjoying the banter and subtle plot that was showing through.

Then Izuku made a delighted hum and showed his phone screen to him.

“Look,” Izuku exclaimed happily. “Here’s some classical music composition classes for you.”

Katsuki blinked once. Then he blinked again. He slowly took the phone, and just like Izuku said there it was. It was only about a twenty-minute walk away and affordable. Katsuki snapped his eyes back at Izuku who was grinning wide at him and the screen.

“This can be your second life, Kacchan,” Izuku said. “You should sign up tonight and we can go to the classes that start next month together. I’ll just sit in the corner but I would love to see you do this. I can picture you as a composer already. You’d be so awesome at it.”

“You really think so?” Katsuki asked, unsure if that could ever be true.

Izuku nodded in confidence. “I would bet my life on it. You’d be amazing at anything you put your mind to, Kacchan. You already have a great ear for classical music, I bet you’re an amazing musical composer waiting to happen.”

Katsuki’s heart fluttered higher than he ever felt it before.

☽ ☽ ☽

A couple weeks after the picnic, Katsuki decided to prompt Izuku to play violin for him.

Izuku rejected the idea at first, too shy. He was stammering and fidgeting with his ring. But Katsuki was not about to let the nerd back out of something he wrote on his damn list. Being the persistent menace he was, Katsuki insisted he was an audience of one, and Izuku could finally stretch his legs to practice violin all he wanted while his ankle healed.

Izuku seemed nervous for an unspoken reason but agreed eventually.

On the evening Izuku decided to play, it was raining.

The lighting in the living room was dim and slightly moody with only the yellowish tint from the fireplace to illuminate the whole space. But despite the slight strain on his eyes, Izuku's face held the vague golden light well. The various yellow shades brought out his green eyes, round face, and the gentle expression that was somehow always there.

Katsuki plopped down on the red rug he placed in the living room. He laid back on his arms, waiting patiently.

Izuku sat down with his violin in the wooden rocking chair.

For some reason, the freckled man was jittering with nerves as he inspected the instrument like there was invisible writing etched into it. Izuku was clearly staring at something Katsuki couldn't see—or maybe he was lost in a memory. His eyes were glazed over, and he only snapped out of it when Katsuki gently called his name.

Green eyes kept darting back and forth between Katsuki, the fireplace and the white violin in his hands.

"This feels…" Izuku trailed off.

"…Like a long time coming?" Katsuki supplied.

Izuku slowly nodded his head with a sad smile. He then took in a deep breath and started playing the violin.

And he played as beautifully as Katsuki remembers.

Izuku's eyes fluttered closed on natural instinct and Katsuki found himself lost in the same trance. He watched, studying the way Izuku's body swayed. He studied the way he arched. He studied how fucking passionate he was as he began playing that song that tied them together.

The Dance of The Love Birds.

The highs and lows of the song blended like a flowing river with the sound of the rain outside the window. Katsuki sat up slightly, heart rate beginning to be erratic, as Izuku started playing more vigorously. His face seeped into a raw emotion and his brows pinched together as he tossed his head with the chords.

Katsuki sat up all the way now, far more attentive as Izuku lost himself in his craft. His heart felt like a painful string was tugging on it until it was about to rip straight through him as Izuku continued. The haunting melody was the same but felt infinitely dissimilar now. It seemed like it had transformed along with them, grown and withered in all the same ways. The innocence that was once wrapped up in the notes was now gone, leaving behind only evidence of raw, agonizing emotion.

All those feelings the old violinist wanted to capture were a lot more real and excruciating: The pain. The longing. The hurt and separation.

Every note hit was like a different dagger that melted upon impact into Katsuki's flesh. It hurt. It healed. It tore him open and sewed him back together. He could feel the same happen for Izuku as the other man's chest heaved slightly while he played. His nostrils flared at the high flow and his hands tensed as his playing became like he was being puppeteered by all the lost years.

When the song ended, silence fell all around them.

Katsuki stared at Izuku and Izuku stared at him right back.

There was a small cluster of tears hugging Izuku's eyes and quickly he wiped them away.

"S-Sorry," Izuku whispered as he hurried to hide the emotions he let spill out. "I don't know what that was."

Katsuki slowly rose from the rug. He walked over to where Izuku was sitting and cradled his face in his hands. Without warning, Izuku's tears flowed down more, touching his hands and Izuku's chest convulsed slightly.

"I always wanted to play for you," Izuku whispered. "I used to dream of it all the time when I was younger. It's…It's why I started playing violin. I used to think if I played in the plaza, you would come back to me one day if you recognized the song. Even if you didn't recognize me."

Red and green eyes searched each other for a long time until Izuku reached out to touch his cheek. The smaller hand ran along his face so softly like he was a ghost who might disappear. Katsuki stroked Izuku's tears away with his thumb and mustered up all the sincerity inside of his heart.

"You played beautifully, darling," Katsuki said.

☽ ☽ ☽

When they went to sleep that night, something was different.

Izuku clung to him much tighter, and Katsuki clung to Izuku much tighter as well. The ticking clock in the background was loud, and this time they didn't play any movie. The silence forced Katsuki to face how much time had slipped away from them yet again. It had been nearly four weeks and soon it'd be a full month.

He hadn't even realized between the trips to the store, the cleaning, the picnics. It all felt like blending moments in a river that flowed downstream without notice.

But it felt like once again their time was escaping them. Just like when they were kids. Just like at the hotel. He viewed Izuku's cast that night differently. It was no longer broken fragments of bone, but rather broken fragments of time that Katsuki knew they both were desperately clutching on to.

As he fell asleep that night, he dreamed he was falling backwards out of darkness.

It was the opposite of what his dreams normally were: falling into darkness. Usually, he fell and fell until he was pushed into his memory with younger Izuku and the snow.

Now he started off with present day Izuku, in the summer air in a vast field of pink carnation petals. The freckled man was laughing in a soft light and slowly his flower crown shifted into being constructed of pink carnations. The natural perfume of the flowers wafted into Katsuki and made him reach out towards Izuku.

But as he did, abruptly, he was cut short.

Suddenly the field of petals stained from bright pink to dark as a black hole. All the light in the field was swallowed by an overflow of black roses with blood staining their petals. Both of them looked around confused when the black roses increased more and more, threatening to consume them in their tide of darkness. Katsuki tried to reach out again, to save Izuku, but invisible hands on his shoulders violently pulled him upwards and away from the other man.

Katsuki screamed and he tried to struggle against the invisible force carrying him away, and slowly dream Izuku's face fell. He mouthed '*Kacchan*?' to him in a broken voice and tried to reach out for him too.

But slowly Izuku faded into the darkness below him, engulfed entirely. Gone. Katsuki struggled harder to swim down, but he only drifted further and further away from Izuku, stretching his hand to him.

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki gasped awake in a sharp startle. He sat up on the bed full force, and all the energy in his bones drained like someone had cut a vein. Katsuki groaned and grabbed at his head.

What the hell?

He *seriously* needed to figure out why he always had dreams as fucked up as that. And why they were always about fucking Izuku. Maybe he should give Momo a call in the future since he has free time now. He could finally get that damn therapy session he *apparently* needed.

The moonlight rested against his face, drawing his eyes slightly open. Out of instinct, or possibly habit, he reached out for the body that was usually beside him.

But his heart dropped when he felt nothing.

Katsuki was now fully awake. He turned his head sharply, and his stomach dropped to see an empty bedside.

"Izuku?" Katsuki called out.

He furrowed his brows and scanned the room. The door to the bedroom was open, and Izuku's crutches were gone. A spark of urgency surged through Katsuki, and he immediately sprung out of bed. He grabbed the nearest set of sweatpants and wandered into the dark hallway.

He called out Izuku's name again, much louder. However, the only answer he got in return was the howling wind blowing through one of the open windows.

His anxiety crept up like crawling insects. What if Izuku left?

No. Izuku couldn't have abandoned him like that, right?

Izuku wouldn't. No, he *couldn't*. Not with his leg all fucked up and they still had to discuss that goddamn divorce.

Katsuki's heart rate increased a bit, and he started his search. He wearily called out Izuku's name throughout the empty hallways. He waited for a moment, hoping silence wouldn't be his only companion but he was wrong. He never got an answer in return, only the wooden floorboards creaking underneath his weight as he walked around.

He checked the bathroom first, thinking maybe he was overreacting. Izuku could be peeing but when Katsuki flung open the door, the entire bathroom was empty.

Next, he checked the kitchen. Empty. The living room, empty. The dining room, empty. He checked every space he could think of, and as he did his gut twisted tighter and tighter until it felt like it was going to blow like a geyser.

His paranoia kicked in, and the eyes from the photographs he had taken down were watching his every move. He could feel all the family members he never knew scrutinizing him somehow. They were studying his every move, and for the first time in a month, Katsuki felt like a stranger in these hallways.

He could feel those insistent whispers telling him he was alone again, and that this interim peace with Izuku was short lived.

When he checked every room he could think of, there was one left he hadn't dared touch.

The nursery.

Then when he rounded the corner, it was propped open with a soft light spilling out of it into the darkness. Quiet shuffling could be heard from inside and Katsuki felt his whole stomach turn inside out.

He rushed forward, slamming open the door harshly. He gazed around at the well-lit room and the baby blue lamp with small ducks on it. The cursed thing was shedding light all over with a freshly changed bulb. Katsuki's raging eyes snapped downwards to find Izuku on the floor in his blue pajamas, picking up pieces of the shattered plaster.

Izuku's mouth hung open in shock and all color drained from his flush face. "Ka-Katsuki. Wait—"

"—What the fuck Izuku?" Katsuki seethed. He looked around and tried his best not to stare at his name written in scarlet on the wall. Shocks of pain ripped into him the longer he stood there in this damned room. "What the actual *fuck*?! I said not to come in here!"

Izuku held one of his hands up while the other curled around pieces of the shattered plaster. “I-I know but I wanted to see—”

“—*No*!” Katsuki cut off unkindly, raising his voice. “If I say not to come in here, don’t fucking do it! This is *my* house. I don’t even want to be in here right now—”

He caught sight of the crib across the room and his throat slammed shut.

The walls started to bend inwards as his eyes darted around. The taunting tune of the baby mobile struck inside of his head like stinging knives and the air flowing inside of him became constricted. Shallow. Short.

Katsuki shook his head when he realized he was spiraling.

Fuck. Get a grip. Get a grip. Get a goddamn grip.

He stepped backwards and cursed when he cut his heel on a small, jagged piece of porcelain. He looked down and saw the crude smear of bright red blood on the floor. There was so much of it. It was seeping out, slithering between the floorboards and making its mark. Suddenly the combination of seeing blood in *this* particular room forced the visual of his mother’s dead body to the forefront of his brain.

Izuku’s face grew increasingly concerned when he saw Katsuki’s chest convulse.

Quickly, Izuku tried to stand up with the help of the dresser when he realized his mistake. He held the broken pieces close to his chest as he called out Katsuki’s name. When his voice couldn’t break past the barrier of panic that was induced, Izuku hobbled forward and tried to reach out his hand.

“Kacchan. I’m sorry—” Izuku lightly touched Katsuki’s shoulder.

It happened in an instant.

Out of reflex, Katsuki shoved Izuku’s hand away. He shoved hard with his natural strength, feeling too overwhelmed to be touched in that moment. By the time he registered he wasn’t shoving away some invisible entity suffocating him, it was too late.

Katsuki’s heart dropped when Izuku toppled backwards, losing grip on the shelf.

The other man cried out as he hit the ground hard, and a pain filled gasp could be heard when Izuku’s head cracked on the wooden floor. The pieces of the broken plaster rolled across the ground and Katsuki’s chest dropped hard enough to make him sick.

“Shit. *Shit*,” Katsuki whispered in a daze. He dropped down to his knees and reached out to steady Izuku. “Iz-Izuku I’m sorry.”

“It’s okay,” Izuku muttered. He lifted himself up on his forearms, wincing. “You didn’t mean it. It was a reflex.”

“No. It’s not okay. I’m sorry. I’m so fucking sorry,” Katsuki insisted. He quickly gathered Izuku up in his arms and inspected his wrapped wrist and ankle. Stupid. How could he be so goddamn *stupid*— “I didn’t mean to make you fall like that. I would never hurt you on purpose, fuck. I’m so goddamn sorry.”

“You didn’t hurt me, Kacchan. It was an accident. I fell.” Izuku smiled at him and sat up fully and glanced down at his lap. “I shouldn’t have come in here anyways. I get so curious sometimes...I can’t help it but I didn’t realize this room was…*yours*.”

Katsuki wearily glanced around at the dust covered shelves and the scattered broken pieces on the floor. His heart slowly calmed with Izuku in his arms, and he clung slightly to the other man. He hung his head down bitterly.

“It…It’s not *mine*,” Katsuki bit out after a stretch of silence.

It took all his strength to glance up. He forced himself to finally stare at his name written in red on the wall.

It was old, chipped away and parts of the wallpaper were folding forward. It looked like it was weeping, trying to reach towards him. He wanted to reach back and touch it for the first time, but the pain in his chest stopped him. It all felt like too much in that moment as he looked up at it.

As he was staring at his name, trying to decode it like his own portrait was on the wall, Izuku’s hand slid over his own. He gripped back on instinct and held on tightly as if Izuku was his lifeline. And maybe he was after all these years.

“I don’t like coming in here, Izuku,” Katsuki confessed with pain etched into his sharp features. “I tried. *So* many fucking times. But I can’t stand being in here.”

“I’m really sorry,” Izuku said honestly. “I didn’t mean to upset you. Let’s get back to bed.”

“It’s okay now,” Katsuki said. He looked around bitterly. “I guess this helped rip the bandaid off. I have to do something with this room eventually, I can’t leave it as an open wound. I nearly had a fucking panic attack just stepping foot in here. I guess I’m more fucked up than I realize.”

“You’re not fucked up,” Izuku rejected gently.

“I am,” Katsuki scoffed. “Don’t even try to make me feel better. I’m fucked up but the worst part is I’m unnecessarily fucked up.”

“What do you mean?” Izuku questioned. He pinched his brows together trying to piece together the jigsaw of Katsuki.

“This room is proof my mother lied to me. All my goddamn life,” Katsuki explained. He didn’t know why he said it, but the tenderness of Izuku coaxed it out of him. “I don’t want to be mad at her because she’s dead, so I avoid things that make me realize she screwed up being a mother.”

Izuku didn't say anything, he let Katsuki continue to speak as he also glanced up at the writing on the wall.

"It's why I didn't remember you right away. I chose to forget Tokyo for a long time because it made it easier to do what I needed to do. Then I avoided this estate because it makes me so goddamn angry to know I could've been *here* all this time, living a goddamn normal life…I used to justify that I was a monster because I *had* to be. But this—" He gestured angrily to his name on the wall. "—Rejects that."

"A monster?" Izuku softly interjected.

"Yes. A fucking *monster*. But worst of all I feel like no one understands what I feel like," Katsuki murmured. "I have colleagues who had *really* fucked up lives with no way around it. No path or outcome would change them from being the serial killers they are today. But there's something so goddamn excruciating about knowing I *didn't* have to be this fucking monster this whole time. I could have been normal…there was a way for me to be normal, but I didn't have a fucking say in the decision."

Izuku gripped the hem of his shirt. "…I get it."

Katsuki made a confused face. "Izuku—"

"—No, really. I get where you're coming from," Izuku insisted. He licked his lips hesitantly. "I went out and found my birth mother one day when I was thirteen."

Katsuki stayed quiet, shocked.

"I thought that if I found her, she would take me in." Izuku looked down at his hands and slowly traced an old scar that was slashed across his palm. "I spent so much time building her up in my head, deluding myself that I was kidnapped and not sold. But when I found her, she was with her new family, and had a *new* baby. She—She made it very clear she didn't want anything to do with me when I revealed I was her son."

Katsuki sucked in a breath, trying to imagine young Izuku standing there getting told such a thing. He could see Izuku's large doe eyes filled with tears. He couldn't even fucking imagine what it would be like to have an illusion shattered like that.

"It hurt more than anything I could think of," Izuku whispered. His eyes glossed over, and tears started gathering inside of them. "She was living her new life with a new *son*. To this day I wonder what it would be like if I wasn't given away. I…I keep track of them and she's a good mom to him."

Katsuki curled his fists tightly.

"I realized then I could've grown up normal too if I something about me was slightly different," Izuku said bitterly. He closed his fingers on the scar and his nostrils flared. "I could've had that life, but it wasn't my decision—and neither was yours. So, we're the same," Izuku concluded. "But be glad you made it through and now you get a shot at a normal life. Better late than never, right?"

He looked up at Katsuki from underneath his long lashes with a deeply broken stare.

“I’m sorry you had to go through all of that, Izuku,” Katsuki said in a soft rasp. He held on tighter to Izuku and the gears in his head started turning. He didn’t want Izuku to go back to the place he was fucking sold to. “You didn’t deserve any of that. I wish I could fucking fix it for you. You’re much more than her decision.”

“And you’re more than your mother’s choices too I’m sure,” Izuku said. “B-But what I’m saying is we’re the same. I understand you, and out of anyone, I get it. We were both one decision away from not being…*monsters*. She hurt you by keeping this from you.”

Katsuki’s shoulders sagged forward, and Izuku carefully ran his hand through his hair. The simple realization of him being hurt by his mother were words he could never admit.

She had hurt him.

His mom had hurt him so fucking *much*.

Izuku scooted in to hug him and Katsuki slowly hugged him back. They both silently looked around the nursery. Then they tiredly leaned against the wall underneath his painted name.

Katsuki saw the ghost figures of his mother and grandparents and he wondered how warm his first welcome into this house was. He could envision all the loving embraces and feel the gentle radiant glow of the care he always longed for. Then slowly the phantoms faded, and he was left with nothing but chills grappling at his bones.

The self-deprecating whispers were in his head, and they were coming in full force. He clung tighter to Izuku who picked up on his distress and hugged him tightly.

“Are you okay?” Izuku asked carefully.

Upon hearing that simple question, Katsuki’s well-built wall collapsed upon itself.

“No,” Katsuki’s voice cracked. “I’m *not*.”

He clung harder to Izuku and as he did so, the warmth of Izuku’s beating heart was a catalyst for all the words to pump out of him.

He retold everything he went through from start to finish and didn’t bother leaving out any details.

He could feel Izuku’s grasp on him tighten at certain points in his story. Izuku clung tighter when he told him about the missed meals. Living with the lights off. Skipping homework and getting bad grades in order to help pay for his mother’s bills. Then finally Izuku cursed out loud when he retold about the man he killed when he was thirteen.

Retelling it all felt like swallowing hot coals. Each detail scarred him as he stomached it in full, unfiltered detail. It was viscous like bitter honey. This was his first time telling it back and Katsuki realized how much it was for his short lifespan. He was so influenced by his

mother, and even now continued to be affected by her influence beyond the grave to the point he could barely walk into a *room*.

When he finished telling how he found this estate, his grip on Izuku grew unnaturally tight.

He feared this was it, Izuku would definitely leave him now. He would walk right out this house and go back to Tokyo after realizing what a fucking monster he was. He would realize he was unstable and not savable, just like everyone else in his life realized he was.

Neither of them said anything for several long moments.

Katsuki slowly peeled himself from Izuku's hold and it was then he realized he had been silently crying the entire time. He touched his face in surprise, confused as to why he didn't register it.

He wearily glanced at Izuku's face, and it was an expression he had never seen before: understanding.

It was warm, delicate like freshly picked flowers and clear as day. Pure understanding shined through Izuku's glossy eyes, making the vibrant greenness of his iris more intense. Izuku slowly shook his head sadly and cradled Katsuki's face in his warm palms. Katsuki leaned into the touch wordlessly, wrapping his hands around Izuku's wrists in a gentle hold.

"Katsuki…" Izuku spoke his name with a broken voice. Tears started to pour from Izuku's eyes. "I don't think you're the monster you think you are."

"Yes, I am," Katsuki said. He averted his gaze shamefully. "How can you say that after hearing what I've done? Especially to my own biological father?"

"To me it sounds like you did it all in the name of protecting *her*." Izuku forced his head up to look into his eyes and caressed his cheeks with affection. "You did everything out of love."

Katsuki wished he could believe that when felt that dark side of him thirst for Chizome's blood.

He was unsure but gradually, the remains of the stone wall surrounding his heart caved the longer Izuku's beautiful viridian eyes melted into him. The softest, kindest smile he has ever seen was graced upon him as Izuku tilted his head.

"You're so loving, Katsuki," Izuku whispered. "I think you're the fiercest, most protective person I've ever met. You deserve everything you want and *more* and it's okay to want it. Despite what you've done—Chizome should be *dead* for what he did to you and your mother."

Katsuki let out a shaky sigh. "You're the only one who seems to think that."

"I think your supervisor thinks it too," Izuku muttered. "But he is protecting you because he cares about you. Maybe you shouldn't kill Chizome yourself—but that man deserves his karma. And there are other ways."

Katsuki held onto Izuku's wrists tighter upon hearing that.

"Do…Do you care about me?"

"I more than care about you," Izuku whispered vulnerably. His eyes softened with an unnamed emotion. "I-I've cared about you since we were kids and I don't think I could ever stop. Even in the years apart, I cared about you as the guy I met in Vienna. I will probably care about you even when my ankle heals and we go our separate ways."

Slowly, Izuku leaned in and placed a delicate, light kiss on his forehead. "You're not a monster. You're human."

"But I can't even be soft," Katsuki muttered. The wound of his insecurities were pulsing in the open as he curled more into Izuku, their legs tangled together. "No matter how hard I try I always hurt everyone I touch."

"You're soft with me," Izuku said with a smile.

Katsuki furrowed his brow.

"I-I may not have spent a lot of time with you like others, but you're so soft with me." Izuku grinned affectionately and joy radiated through his smile. "You were soft when we were kids. You were soft at the hotel when you tried to pretend to be my husband. You were soft on the boat. On the beach. While hiking." Izuku's face blushed slightly and his voice dropped into a quieter tone. "…Even in bed, you took care of me so nicely even though I was nervous. And even in the last month, you've been very soft with me."

All the moments played in his head like a small flip book. He could vividly see himself being tender with Izuku. It was pouring through his memories, and he hadn't even noticed it.

"You can be soft, Katsuki," Izuku concluded with a gentle smile.

Katsuki tears slowly stopped as something dawned on him. He looked at Izuku, his own hands and the way they were cradled against each other in the room amongst the broken pieces of his past.

Gradually, the golden light of sunrise leaked into the window at that moment, haloing Izuku's dark curls with a rim of light. Katsuki's heart rate tripled as he viewed Izuku in an entirely different lens than before.

He reached out to hold Izuku's face too.

They searched each other's eyes for a long moment, heart rates increasing.

It clicked together like forgotten memories that Katsuki would only dream of holding. All the whispers in his head that told him he wasn't deserving of love went silent and all he could hear or see was Izuku. Beautiful, kind Izuku. An unspoken warmth pulled in his chest.

Katsuki slowly leaned in, fluttering his eyes closed. Izuku closed his eyes too and held on to him like he was a lifeline in the vast sea.

Their lips met together in a gentle, passionate kiss.

Katsuki’s heart soared to a height it had never been. He deepened the kiss delicately and pulled Izuku into him. He caressed Izuku’s scarred hands and poured all his soul out at that moment. He realized Izuku brought out the softness in him that others never could.

Maybe Izuku was his missing piece.

Chapter End Notes

Please let me know what you think!!

Next chapter is gonna be plot and horny times LOL. I didn't thin it would be terribly appropriate for a lot of smut in this chapter since it was trying to show their non-smut intimacy. But next chapter is gonna be...fun :D

Thanks so much for reading 💜

Chapter 15: Dolce

Chapter Summary

Dolce: Stylistic Indication - To Play Sweetly

Chapter Notes

Helloooo! Welcome back to everyone's lovable unhinged husbands! I hope you enjoy this chapter :)

First, big thank you to Luna the love of my life for betaing like always and putting up with me :D Secondly please to check out the songs! I love them this round. Special shout out to Mintyzuku for showing me a lot of these! Thank you for always being so sweet ^^ 💜💕

Okay lets get started!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 15 - Dolce

.

.

.

Katsuki thought he knew every bit of himself through and through. He was sure of it. Every nook and cranny of his mind he was familiar with, even the part that housed that sinister darkness.

However, after Izuku's lips locked with his own in the nursery, an entity inside of him reared its head. It wasn't new, or a spark that had ignited. It had been there, and it was awakening like rusted gears put to use for the first time in years—but Katsuki had no idea what it was.

When they broke from the kiss, all Katsuki could see were beautiful green eyes.

The feeling of Izuku's skin underneath his fingertips was warm. The caress of his breath against his lips was tender. The sleepy, yet adoring expression swimming in Izuku's eyes was passionate. All this combined stirred that rusted sensation inside of Katsuki faster and faster until his heart was hammering in his chest.

Alarmed slightly by this unnamed feeling, Katsuki pulled away.

Katsuki straightened his back and glanced around at all the broken pieces of porcelain scattered on the ground. Beside them were tiny blood speckles that made a trail to him, stemming from the small cut on his own foot.

Izuku followed his line of vision and grimaced. “Sorry for making such a mess in here.”

“It was already a mess,” Katsuki mumbled. He leaned his body over to the broken pieces on the ground and slowly began to gather them up one by one. “But it’s time to clean it up—like all messes, I guess.”

Izuku shifted alongside him. He crawled on his knees on the ground and began picking up the broken pieces of porcelain like they were treasure. Together they collected the fragments in silence, basking in the golden luminescence of the early sun.

When the morning breeze came through the window, it touched Katsuki differently. It danced along his arms and up his shoulders to whisk away the weight of how he felt about his mother. Finally admitting that she had hurt him allowed Katsuki to let go of her a bit more.

They finished gathering all the broken pieces of porcelain and Izuku placed them inside of a small napkin. Katsuki wiped up the spilled blood and applied a Band-Aid to the wound on his foot.

He took one last pitiful glance around the nursery.

It didn’t seem haunted with demons in the same way it had been mere minutes ago. Shamefully, Katsuki felt so damn dramatic for his small episode. He glanced down to Izuku who was patiently waiting on the ground, gazing up at him, studying his every move.

Katsuki bent down to help him up. Izuku wrapped his arms around him without dropping the napkin full of the jagged pieces.

“Let’s get to bed,” Katsuki murmured into Izuku’s curls.

☽ ☽ ☽

As they laid down to go back to bed, Katsuki knew something was different.

He could sense Izuku knew it as well. They cuddled into each other more, molding together as if they needed the other. Katsuki studied his hands holding Izuku. He regarded every ugly scar, callous, and mark on them as he held the warm body firmly against him.

“I could kill Chizome for you,” Izuku whispered into his neck without moving.

Katsuki went still.

He drew back from Izuku so he could see his face. Izuku’s expression was gentle yet furious. Deep green eyes then slowly inched up to stare at him from underneath thick lashes.

Izuku's grip on him grew tighter. "Once my ankle heals, it could be the first thing I do. I think your supervisor was correct that you shouldn't do it, for your own benefit. But that doesn't mean someone else can't."

The burning passion for Chizome's death in Izuku's eyes matched his own.

Katsuki stared curiously at Izuku, taken back by the offer in a strangely good way.

"You would do that for me?"

"I would do anything for you."

Katsuki's chest hummed with both blood lust, satisfaction and astonishment. He hugged Izuku again and tried to assess the complex emotions boiling inside of his chest when that unnamed feeling smiled at the thought of Izuku killing Chizome.

☽ ☽ ☽

The following day was leisure and Katsuki finally decided to clean out the nursery.

He decided to push thoughts of Chizome aside for now and would revisit them later. He wanted to first get his life here set up, and then he would potentially take Izuku up on that offer.

Currently, the man in question sat outside the door of the nursery on the ground as he went to work. The little nerd was tinkering with something. He had gotten into the pottery room and limped out with a basket stuffed to the brim with supplies.

However, every time Katsuki tried to take a peek at what Izuku was doing, he was met with a glare. Izuku scrambled and hunched his body over whatever it was to hide it from view.

"No looking!" Izuku chastised. "Focus on cleaning, Kacchan. I'll show you when I'm done."

"And why should I listen to you, Deku darling?" Katsuki teased. He bent down to Izuku's level and grinned with all his teeth. "C'mon, show me what you're doing."

"I will after you finish clearing out the nursery. Think of it like a reward."

"A reward?" Katsuki questioned, unconvinced. "Just show me."

"I said no. You have to wait."

"Seriously?"

"Seriously."

Katsuki frowned. "Whatever, you lil' weirdo. I can't believe you're hiding shit from me in my own damn home."

Katsuki stood up straight and shot Izuku a glare. The other man in return stuck his tongue out at him. Katsuki scoffed at the sheer childish nature of the gesture and shook his head. He resumed cleaning out the nursery with vigor. He worked a little bit faster than he normally would've, reluctantly egged on by the idea of getting whatever Izuku considered a reward.

It took a handful of hours, but Katsuki was able to finally clear out the room.

He threw out all the furniture along with his pain that was attached to it. He and Izuku talked casually and played music in the background as he deep cleaned down to the very last cobweb. By the time it was finished, the only thing left in the room was his name painted on the wall.

He wiped his brow of sweat and stared up at the red letters.

"What should I even use this room for?" Katsuki questioned.

He crossed his arms and stared around at the tiny room. It was big enough for basically a baby—nothing else.

"We can make it your music room," Izuku happily suggested. "You're starting your classical music composing class soon. You deserve a space of your own dedicated to it."

Katsuki's eyebrows shot up. "Ah. That's a great idea—"

He turned his head towards Izuku, ready to say more but the words stopped on the edge of his tongue. Izuku was grinning up at him and pointing down to an item on the ground.

Laying there on a tiny piece of tarp was the broken plaster of his baby feet. It was perfectly put back together with gold shimmering in the cracks.

Katsuki's heart stopped.

He walked towards the recovered piece from his past and halted directly in front of it. He curiously aligned his large foot with the tiny feet.

"You put it back together," Katsuki whispered. His face pinched in pain. "Why?"

"I was originally going to throw it out like you said to," Izuku started. He traced his finger along the golden lines. "But, when I started to piece it together, I realized what it was." Izuku's eyes watered and blinked rapidly. "I-I don't th-think you should get rid of this. Its… Its proof people loved you as a child."

If eyes really were the window to the soul, then Izuku left his eyes wide open for Katsuki to walk into at that moment. It was easy to tell this wasn't all about Katsuki.

Possibly Izuku was hoping there was a plaster with his baby feet out there as well. Or maybe he was hoping his mother regretted her decision despite what she had said to him. Those were Katsuki's best guesses. But they were just that, guesses.

Katsuki squatted to Izuku's level. He glanced at the plaster and took Izuku's hand in his. He intertwined their fingers like weaving ribbons.

"I'll keep it because you worked so hard on it." Katsuki decided that this fucked up part of his past was valuable now that Izuku had taken a liking to it. "When I finish redecorating this room, I'll hang it up, okay?"

Izuku's eyes sparkled. "Okay."

He stole a cliché kiss from Izuku and smiled. "Thank you for this. You're very thoughtful."

Katsuki adored the way Izuku blushed.

☽ ☽ ☽

For the redesigns Katsuki went with a deep wine color. The new red paint swallowed up the old like fresh blood bleeding over wounds from the past.

When enough layers were applied, any remains of what the room used to look like were gone. In place of the crib now was a small mahogany desk. On top it were endless blank music sheets and fountain pens. Where the dresser for his unused baby clothes was now a shelf for where he would put his record collection—whenever he rebuilt it.

Lastly, where it used to say 'Katsuki' was a blank slate and underneath it was a lone music stand.

There was only one touch missing, and he was currently hanging it up. He swung the iron hammer with purpose as Izuku cheered in the background. The nail drove into the old wood with a sharp crack, and more glee erupted from Izuku.

Katsuki picked up the plaster of his baby feet. The glue was all dried and the golden powder had set into the cracks. He carefully hung it up on the door, and then slowly took a step back. From this distance, he joined Izuku in admiring it. The man beside him hummed happily, leaning on his crutches with a satisfied grin.

"Perfect," Izuku whispered. "Your very own music study. I can't wait for you to use this."

Katsuki crossed his arms and stared at Izuku. That unnamed emotion in his chest occurred once more.

"Yeah, it's starting to feel like home."

☽ ☽ ☽

The next two weeks passed and Katsuki was suddenly nervous. All the anxiety in his body jittered around like someone was shaking him harshly in a glass jar.

He tapped his foot anxiously in the small room he was in. It had several windows and a white board in front that was full of music stanzas and notes.

Off to the side was a sleek, black grand piano and several music stands. Spread around in a disorderly fashion were chattering people he had never met before. Normally, this wouldn't be a threat to him. But right now, his instincts were treating this the same as an assignment where he once had to slaughter five men twice his size.

"Kacchan. Are you okay?" Izuku's distant voice suddenly sliced through all his thoughts.

Katsuki blinked rapidly, coming out of his daze.

Izuku stared at him with intense worry. His head was tilted, and his small hand was perched on Katsuki's shoulder.

"I'm fine," Katsuki automatically replied. He shook himself out of his own mind to focus on Izuku. "Why do you ask?"

"Well. You've been muttering for five minutes now," Izuku whispered. He glanced around at the other people, who were staring at them wearily. "Er, a little bit loud. You were mapping out an escape plan…and sizing people up in case you needed to take them down."

"Shit. Sorry about that." Katsuki winced. "Force of habit."

"I figured." Izuku ran a hand through Katsuki's hair and cupped his cheek. "Try not to scare everyone off on the first day."

"I can't make any promises," Katsuki replied snidely. He stared to his right at the young woman who scooted over a seat to get further away from him. He pursed his lips and turned to Izuku with a stare drenched with worry. "Are you sure this isn't…dumb?"

Izuku cocked his head. "Why would this be dumb?"

"Because it feels fuckin' dumb," Katsuki said sourly. He picked at the music sheets in his lap. "I missed my chance to follow music. I should just focus on landscaping and crap to fucking atone or something."

"Kacchan. Just give it a shot." Izuku touched his hand. "I-I can't explain it well, but I think you should do this. It'll give you something to focus on besides *landscaping*."

Katsuki squeezed Izuku's hand back. "Alright."

Izuku touched their foreheads together.

When the instructor came into the room, he was a man who looked as if he had lived life well. He had a happy, rounded face with rosy cheeks. He smelled of freshly peeled oranges with hair as white as lilies. In his hands was a brown leather suitcase that had tiny corners of sheet music peeking through the cracks and his bright grin reflected the glow from the sun.

"Good morning everyone!" The man's voice boomed through the room. "I'll be your teacher for the Classical Music Composition class. I'm Mr. Nakano and it's such a delight to get to know everyone."

Katsuki smiled slightly. He leaned back in his chair and relaxed as the instructor began to write the first lesson plan on the white board. He had neat handwriting, Katsuki thought to himself privately.

He was about to take notes and make a comment about the man's ridiculously long beard to Izuku—but when he turned his head he saw Izuku with his nose already stuck up in his book.

Well, Katsuki thought. *I suppose he had no interest in music composition.*

Katsuki returned his attention back to the teacher.

The class carried on and Katsuki absorbed every lick of information happily. Even though this was only the beginning stages, Katsuki could remember faint little pieces of the past from the looney violinist coming back to him. All the fancy terms he never had real meaning for now were clicking into place. Staccato. Dissonance. Descendo. It all was familiar now, in the best possible way.

However, something curious gripped Katsuki's attention throughout the hour-long lecture.

Every time he took a small break from taking notes, he glanced over at Izuku next to him.

His accidental husband was holding back a smile, biting at his bottom lip. He leaned down in his chair with his book all the way up to his face—as if trying to hide his blush. But what was strangest was how Izuku kept fucking squirming.

Katsuki frowned when Izuku squeezed his thighs together and his blush deepened. Sharp, well trained hitman eyes narrowed in on the way the book was parted and it was beginning to look familiar.

Katsuki turned his attention back to the instructor. But a small question played in the back of his mind: Why the hell did Izuku always act giddy at that part of the book?

☽ ☽ ☽

"Did you have fun?" Izuku asked as he wobbled into the living room. He plopped down on the couch with a large smile and set down his crutches. "You seemed really into it the whole time!"

"Oh hell yeah," Katsuki replied. He sat down next to Izuku with an excited grin. "Most fun I had in a while."

"What did you like most about it?"

"Everything. It was damn cool to finally see all that shit make sense. I never really thought about different types of scales in music or all that crap until today. Or more so, I didn't realize it had names until now. Like who would have thought there was only a handful but there's so many combinations to make all these sounds. I wonder if Bach or—"

Katsuki caught himself when Izuku's eyes widened with delight.

He cursed under his breath. “I’m rambling.”

“Please, continue on,” Izuku snickered. He leaned forward into Katsuki’s space teasingly. “I haven’t heard you speak this passionately since planning to take down Moore.”

“No, I’m stopping myself,” Katsuki mumbled. He shoved Izuku back and shook his head. “All that fucking muttering you do to yourself in the bathroom is officially rubbing off on me.”

“I know!” Izuku chuckled, clasping his hands together. “It’s great!”

“I’m going to go make dinner to help forget that I’m picking up your god-awful habit,” Katsuki quipped. He rose from the couch and sauntered over to the kitchen area across the way. He ignored Izuku’s playful calling of his pet name as he started to take out all the pots and pans.

Eventually Izuku turned his attention to his book once more.

Katsuki stayed occupied with the food, attempting not to fucking mutter. He would be damned if, out of all the fucking habits in the world, he would pick *that* up from Izuku.

He focused on testing out a new recipe that he had seen online, and he thought Izuku may like it too. When he peeked back at the other man, he saw Izuku stretched out on his back on the couch. He was holding the book up with both of his arms and a giggle danced across his plump lips.

Katsuki narrowed in on the way the book was split. It was opened again in that same spot—slightly at the end but not far enough. The spine looked the most worn in that position on top of it.

He carefully placed the seasoned chicken in the oven and set his timer. He walked over to Izuku silently, trying his best not to trip his senses.

Usually when Izuku read whatever shit was on that page, he was far gone. All his goddamn assassin training was out the window when his big ass eyes were glued to those sentences. Which made it extremely easy for Katsuki to sneak around the back of the couch and crouch down.

Using all the stealth he had in his body, Katsuki crawled without making any noise. Then he sprung up with a mischievous grin and Izuku startled immediately. The smaller man scrambled the best he could with his wounded ankle and Katsuki sprung over the couch.

“Kacchan!” Izuku yelped, trying to hide his laughter. “Wh-What are you doing?!”

“Top secret mission—” Katsuki announced, chuckling as well. “Obtain your dorky book and read whatever it is you keep smiling at.”

He pinned Izuku down by his chest to the couch with his knee. With all the agility of an angel Katsuki snatched the tattered book and Izuku’s smile dropped immediately.

“N-No!” Izuku protested loudly. “Th-That’s private! You can’t read that part of the book!” He thrashed around, attempting to roll Katsuki over but Katsuki sat on him in return, earning a groan. Izuku fruitlessly shoved Katsuki until he was red in the face. “Ka-Kacchan, I’m serious! You can’t read it!”

“Hah? So you can force me to read the beginning of this book when the fucking man gets lost in the goddamn desert for one hundred pages, but I can’t read what’s clearly your favorite part?” Katsuki laughed as he ignored Izuku’s frantically growing struggles. “I bet it’s some sappy shit like a poem. My money is on him climbing a tower and she lets her hair down—whoa, wait. What the fuck?”

“Kacchan,” Izuku mumbled mournfully. He slowly hid his face in his arms. “Please…don’t read it.”

Katsuki didn’t listen and his mouth dropped in disbelief.

“This is fucking *porn*.”

His eyes widened as he reread the sentence that very metaphorically described a blow job. A very wet and sloppy one—but it didn’t stop there. Soon the whole paragraph was leading into another which led to another which led to straight out fucking.

“Holy shit,” Katsuki uttered. He blinked rapidly in surprise, ignoring the tiny groans of agony beneath him. “This is just as bad as the websites I’m subscribed to.”

“Wait.” Izuku halted for a moment. His face twisted with mild jealousy. “What websites are *you* subscribed to?”

Ignoring Izuku’s question, Katsuki flipped the page to find more sex being described. “I can’t believe what the hell I’m seeing. All this time you’ve been reading literary porn right in front of me.”

“It’s not porn,” Izuku countered. He gritted his teeth as he covered his face with his hands. “It-It’s romantic intimacy! They had been building up to this moment for most of the book and it’s a hallmark of their relationship and trust after being apart for so long—”

“—I would believe that if this book didn’t just use the phrase ‘*fluttering hole*’.”

Izuku whined loudly.

“Wait,” Katsuki said slowly. He sat up a bit. “You’ve been reading this since we got to the hotel. Is that why you were always squirming and smiling at this damn book at night? You were reading the same passage of someone getting railed over and over.”

Izuku hid in his hands further. “*Katsuki*.”

“And you had the audacity to call *me* the pervert.”

“Okay! Yes! I like that part a lot, alright!” Izuku huffed. He snapped his hands down and glared his furious green eyes at Katsuki. His skin was flushed pink all the way down to his

collarbone and his shirt dropped off his shoulder ever so slightly. “Are you happy? Can you stop teasing me now?”

“Not a chance in hell.”

Katsuki grinned wide and shifted. He moved his legs on either side of Izuku, caging him in. He leaned over the smaller man with a purpose. Izuku’s eyes widened, and his blush deepened to the perfect shade of red.

“Are you horny, Izuku?” Katsuki asked in his lowest voice. “Is that why you keep reading this part over and over again? Does my darling *husband* want to be *ravished*?”

He meant it as a joke. He wanted to poke fun at the fact that the main characters in the book were married, but when he said the word ‘husband’ his stomach tightened, and he could feel Izuku stiffen.

“Please don’t say it like that,” Izuku mumbled, screwing his eyes shut.

Katsuki studied the words on the page then looked at Izuku’s tell-all: thighs squeezing together. Katsuki leaned down until his body was nearly laying directly on top of Izuku’s. He could feel the other man’s heart pound.

“And why not?” Katsuki questioned. “It seems to get you going. Which did you like—ravished or husband?” He waited for a beat and a small shiver went down Izuku’s body at the last word. “Ah. *Husband*. Makes sense that you’d have a hidden spousal kink.”

Izuku’s whole body erupted in flames—and then his assassin instincts kicked in.

Katsuki’s vision was tilted backwards as Izuku sprung his whole body forward and caught him in a headlock. Scarlet eyes widened with surprise, and Izuku flipped their positions while keeping his ankle protected. Katsuki made a disgruntled sound at the sudden choke hold and within the blink of an eye, the book was snatched out of his grasp.

When he obtained his bearings again, he was belly down and Izuku was crawling on his hands and knees with the book towards his crutches.

“Aw, darling, I didn’t mean any harm by it,” Katsuki teased with a smirk. He leaned up on his elbows and grinned. “I’m only curious what you’re into. If you have some dirty fantasies in that virginal noggin of yours, I’m more than happy to act them out with you.”

“Stop teasing me and I’m not a virgin anymore!” Izuku hissed angrily, nape redder than a tomato. “I-I’m hiding this from you! If you touch it I’m going to stab you!”

“You can try. Nothing can stay hidden from me.”

Izuku huffed and crawled away.

☽ ☽ ☽

Izuku didn't hide the book well—or maybe he did, and Katsuki was just good at finding things.

Tracking and hunting has always been his specialty and that even went for that tiny, worn-down book. In the depths of night, Katsuki found it tucked away in some dark cloth on the back of the pottery shelf in a large vase. It was perfectly disguised and out of sight, but Izuku underestimated his visual memory. Katsuki had seen the vase moved ever so slightly out of place and he knew immediately to go for it.

He acquired the book like he won a prize and opened up to the exact page number he committed to memory. He sat in the living room while Izuku was knocked out asleep in their bedroom. There was a small lamp giving way to yellowish tinted light on the page.

Katsuki thought maybe this would be a fun way to see what type of filthy shit his innocent Izuku was into—but it wasn't exactly as dirty as he thought it would be.

Rose petals. Longing. Deep thrusts. Peppered kisses. Catering to each other's every whim.

This was soft.

Katsuki put the book down in his lap and stared blankly at the ground.

Well. That was anticlimactic and nowhere near as filthy as he would have hoped. He drew the conclusion that this made sense, Izuku *was* a hopeless romantic. Of course, the nerd would be interested in gentle sex—but. Katsuki's mind wandered back to Okinawa and how what they did was the exact opposite of what this book entailed.

Was *this* how Izuku imagined his first time?

A trickle of guilt fell over Katsuki.

Then, a small sound similar to a screw dropping echoed. It sounded as if it came from the bedroom.

Katsuki perked up, more alert.

He slid his hand in-between the sofa cushions to pull out a concealed tactical knife. He had placed a couple around the estate, just for good measure. He usually wasn't a paranoid person—but there was never such a thing as 'too careful' after all the horrors he had witnessed and brought about in this lifetime.

The metal of the knife caught the gleam from the lamp as he clutched it. Katsuki slowly closed the book, careful not to make a sound. He wielded the weapon, ready to launch as he heard another noise from the main corridor. Katsuki crept on his toes all the way to the bedroom only to find Izuku sleeping soundly.

He checked around the bedroom and up and down the hallways but found nothing.

All he could hear was the soft snoring of Izuku. Katsuki concluded it was possibly the estate breathing, this place *was* older than he was. Old homes made weird sounds; it was normal.

Katsuki's guard dropped a little when everything checked out.

He refocused on the sight of Izuku's messy curls. The moonlight spilled into the large bed and kissed Izuku's olive skin delicately. Katsuki tucked the weapon into his pants' hem and hesitantly reached out a hand to caress Izuku's cheek. The sleeping man snuggled into the touch and a small smile pulled on his lips. Izuku's freckles seemed painted on—and it caused Katsuki to stop and wonder.

"You can be soft, Katsuki."

Maybe he could try to give Izuku the story book fantasy he always wanted.

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki stayed up all night reading that damned book and taking notes.

Had someone told him that he would be *studying* on how to fuck soft two months ago he would've shot them in the mouth. Had they told him that he would be doing it for the green menace that plagued his life—he would have tortured them for the hell of it.

But life was unpredictable, and so was he and so was Izuku. Therefore, all of this madness somehow made sense if it was the two of them.

"Where are you going?" Izuku questioned the next day. They had finished eating breakfast and Katsuki was putting on his coat for the drop in weather. "Your next music lesson is tomorrow, not today."

"I'm going to run out to the store for some things," Katsuki answered casually. He tried to act natural and not give away his plans. "Will you be okay alone for a couple of hours?"

Izuku nodded cutely. "I think I'll be fine. But can I have a goodbye kiss to hold me over until you get back?"

"Of course, darling." Katsuki leaned down and stole a tiny kiss from Izuku's lips.

They leaned away for a moment before breaking out in smiles. They kissed once more. Then twice. Then thrice and a fourth time until they felt satisfied.

"Okay, last kiss," Katsuki said. "Otherwise, I can keep going all day."

"That doesn't seem like a bad option," Izuku suggested playfully.

Katsuki laughed and shook his head. They exchanged one more kiss and a goodbye before Katsuki finally leaned upright.

As he was walking towards the door, he glanced back at Izuku. He had just wanted to steal a glance at the handsome man once more before he left, but he caught sight of an action that broke the bubble of ignorance they were in.

Izuku took out a small, glass vile in his pocket. He watched Izuku uncap it and tap a small droplet into his smoothie.

Katsuki's happiness faltered and he didn't move.

Neither of them spoke a word on Izuku's steady poisoning of himself. He did it every morning to keep up his immunity with a rotation of various toxins. It was an ugly underlying reminder that Izuku potentially had a very bleak future if he didn't come up with a plan to get him out.

He tightened his grip on the handle of the door when that unnamed emotion inside of him churned unhappily. It pushed against him like nails against a dry chalk board forcing him to clench his jaw and cringe.

Cross that bridge when it arrives, Katsuki reminded himself.

Or burn it so he can never go back, the darker half of himself suggested.

He left out the door and pushed back thoughts of their rings, Izuku's poison, and the number 217 into the recesses of his mind.

☽ ☽ ☽

The sun was setting by the time he finished gathering all he needed. Katsuki muttered to himself as he double checked his list.

Rose petals, pink and red.

Cherry scented candles and bath bombs.

Cushions, pillows and very soft blankets that would be good at resisting any type of friction.

Everything was easy to gather, but the entire time in the shopping district Katsuki couldn't shake the odd feeling of eyes following him.

He looked around different corners, but always found no one suspicious. It was always a simple, happy family standing there with some kids. Or some couple or normal singletons that had their headphones in. No one was paying him any mind, and Katsuki was beginning to wonder if extensive paranoia was a side effect of working for The Company for so long.

He shook off the strange sensation as he stopped in the very last store he needed: a sex store.

Originally, he only meant to buy items that would hold him and Izuku over for a while so he wouldn't have to leave as it got cold. Such as lube and candy g-strings. *Especially* the candy g-strings. However, as he poked around he couldn't help but think Izuku might like this, or that, or many, many things. Any man that drinks poison for breakfast is bound to be a deranged level of kinky deep down.

Then he saw it.

Katsuki pushed up his sunglasses and tilted his head at it. He read the label over and over again to make sure he wasn't seeing things.

Doughnut flavored lube?

He didn't even know Krispy Kreme *made* lube.

A giddy sensation pulsed in his chest. Izuku would fucking die of embarrassment if they used this—it was *perfect*.

Katsuki glanced over his shoulder and pushed his sunglasses back down over his eyes. He quickly threw it in his basket with a smirk.

☽ ☽ ☽

It was night outside when he finished and by that time, Katsuki missed Izuku.

That unidentified piece inside of him was blaring loudly, screaming at him to get back to the cute nerd that was waiting on him. Katsuki looked down at the variety of shopping bags hanging off his arms like ornaments. He was feeling tired but still very much determined to make this shit happen.

He hopped off the train to his final destination, back to the small town of Biei. As he walked to the estate, his body dragged. Then he quickly remembered there was a small coffee shop not too far away and detoured momentarily.

The coffee shop was quiet and full with a handful of local people. The baristas were bubbly and smiling the entire time as the welcoming smell of roasted coffee beans crowded the air. Katsuki put in his order and gave his name and credit card to the young woman at the counter.

He stood off to the side with his arms crossed, casually checking his phone. He had a number of texts and calls he still hadn't answered from his colleagues or Aizawa. He pursed his lips reading one particularly erratic text from Denki, but once again chose to ignore it.

"Medium macchiato," the barista called over the loud music blasting.

She signaled with her hand that the drink was his. She pushed the cup across the counter and turned back around to take another order. Katsuki walked over to pick it up.

However, another hand reached it before he could.

The hand was petite, pale and had long, coffin shaped nails. The color of the nails was a deep red as if they were dipped into a fresh bucket of blood and stained.

Katsuki frowned as the hand picked up his order. He followed the line of the slender arm all the way up to find a young woman with a delicate bone structure. Her blonde hair was pinned up in two messy buns, her lips were coated in a bright cherry stain and her eyes were a captivating gold. But her sights were locked straight on the writing on the cup.

“Excuse me,” Katsuki said pointedly. “That one is mine.”

Her piercing eyes snapped towards him.

He had expected a sense of embarrassment from her but saw nothing staring back at him like a void. Then slowly she smiled, and her expression didn’t reach her eyes.

“Ah! I’m so sorry,” she said quickly. She fake laughed and handed the drink over to him. She covered her mouth as if scandalized. “I must’ve misheard. I thought this was my drink.”

“It’s okay, mistakes happen,” Katsuki muttered.

He grabbed the cup from the woman and surveyed her discreetly. She looked about his age, and for the most part appeared benign. She was dressed in a dark, crimson dress and black leather jacket with matching combat boots. As he inconspicuously studied her, she peeked inside his shopping bags.

“Ooh, scented candles and pretty pillows,” she exclaimed in a sing-song voice. She cocked her head like she was witnessing something intriguing. “Along with a bag of rose petals. Do you have a romantic night planned with someone special?”

“Potentially.” Katsuki didn’t give any room for conversation. “Have a good rest of your night.”

It was a harmless question, but paranoia was crawling into his veins again and he fucking hated small talk. Katsuki decided then it was time to take his leave. The odd sensation he was picking up was overpowering enough to make him uncomfortable.

He turned around and didn’t look back.

“You have a good rest of your night too, Katsuki,” the mysterious woman called out.

Katsuki turned his head to see her smiling at him from over her shoulder.

His eyes glanced down at her feet, and it was then that he saw a snake tattooed on either one of her calves. The twin vipers crawled directly up from her heel to the midpoint of the back of her leg, baring their fangs and forked tongues. He glanced up at her face, and she was turned away, paying him no mind.

Katsuki walked out of the coffee shop regretting his pitstop. He looked down at his cup of coffee and frowned. He glared at his name written on the cup in red marker right above the contents of his order.

“Damn my fucking paranoia,” Katsuki grumbled angrily.

He knew he was being ridiculous—but he poured the coffee into the river on his way back and put the cup in the next trash can he saw. He never drank out of a cup he didn’t touch first, and he wasn’t about to start now.

Harmless mix up or not.

☽ ☽ ☽

“You’re back!” Izuku exclaimed. His doe eyes sparkled against the artificial light in the kitchen. “What took you so long—oh wow. That’s a lot of bags! What’s inside of them?”

Izuku hobbled up to him at the door, and Katsuki bit his tongue. He grinned wide and held up the bags out of Izuku’s line of vision.

“It’s a surprise,” Katsuki replied with a hint of humor. Izuku frowned in the cutesy way he always did. “I got something planned out for us that I think you’ll fucking geek over.”

Immediately Izuku’s frown was chased off. Curiosity blossomed like a field of flowers in his eyes as he stared at the bags. A wide grin split across his face, showing his dimples.

“Sounds fun!” Izuku exclaimed. “I’m excited for whatever you have planned.”

Katsuki grinned, heart pumping loudly in his ears. He was nervous. He *really* hoped he could pull this off how he imagined the scene in Izuku’s head. But even more so, he hoped Izuku liked it and didn’t find it weird.

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki muttered lightly to himself as he lit the third scented candle. The whole bathroom smelled of roses and he was beginning to like the scent of flowers after being immersed in the aroma for so long.

He had the lights turned down halfway, elevating the atmosphere to be more sensual and romantic. He had spent an absurd amount of time mixing whatever fucking bath mix correctly to be the right ratio of ingredients that would be healthy for Izuku’s skin. Then he sprinkled some rose petals on top of the water for visual effect.

This was the exact scene in that damned book Izuku was so attached to. One lover had run a bath for the other to relax fully and used rose petals, candles, and herbs to help set the mood. Katsuki wondered If Izuku would recognize the shoddy recreation as he placed another candle on the sink.

“A bath?” Izuku questioned as he hobbled to the doorway of the bathroom.

Katsuki glanced up from his seat on the floor, trying his best to play it cool. “Yup. A bath. Do you like it?”

Izuku stared at the scene. A flash of recognition snuck on his face, but it was quickly killed, as if questioning himself.

“This looks very pretty but I’m not sure the bathtub is big enough for two people,” Izuku pointed out.

“I’m not getting in,” Katsuki corrected as he checked the temperature of the water. “I already took a shower earlier. I put this together for you.” He smiled as Izuku’s eyes stretched wider with every passing second. “Do you like it?”

'Does it look familiar?' is what Katsuki really wanted to ask.

Izuku stammered and a candy pink blush settled on his cheeks. "I do. This is—" he paused and stared around at the calming, romantic setting. "Th-This is really nice. What's the special occasion?"

"We haven't tried to kill each other in nearly two months," Katsuki answered sarcastically.

Izuku chuckled and sheepishly smiled. "I didn't even realize it had nearly been two months since the beginning of the Okinawa assignment."

"Mhm," Katsuki hummed. He pondered the thought for a while as he took in Izuku. "Time flew by really fast."

"They say time flies by with the right person."

Katsuki paused momentarily. *The right person.*

He eyed Izuku's dimples, and his heart skipped a beat. The unnamed emotion sparked to life again and Katsuki quickly stood up and cleared his throat.

"Well, here you go," Katsuki said in a rush. "Take as long as you need, then come out to the living room after you're done, by the fireplace. Put on the robe before you come out."

Izuku nodded and hobbled up to him to capture him in a surprise hug.

The warmth between their bodies tripled with their heart rates as Izuku snuggled into his chest. He squeezed Katsuki affectionately. Stunned by the sudden contact, Katsuki stood still for a moment. He was unfamiliar with how this felt he realized. He stared at the wall in shock for a split second before he felt like he was melting.

He relaxed all the way and hugged Izuku back.

☽ ☽ ☽

If Katsuki thought he reached the peak of ridiculousness at any other moment of his life, this scene currently beat out anything before that.

He had laid out three layers of plush blankets on the ground in front of the fireplace and formed a small line of soft pillows and cushions on the outer edges. Each pillow and blanket was soft to the touch and pure white with tiny gold embroidered designs. The snap and crackle of the fire next to the set up echoed into the dark living room as Katsuki poured two glasses of wine.

"He better fucking like this," Katsuki grumbled under his breath as he placed down one wine glass. He readjusted the sash on his black, silk robe carefully.

All of his nerves were through the roof now as he stared down at the skimpy robe he was in. This was as close to book accuracy he could get. A path of rose petals led from the bathroom to the living room. Even more petals were laid down within the blankets and two glasses of

red wine were ready to go. The only thing missing was him laying down with a flower in his *mouth*.

Katsuki groaned as he lifted up the single white rose.

He looked at its thornless stem as if it was berating him. Swallowing the last of his pride, Katsuki bit the stem and held it in his mouth. He adjusted himself to be poised and ready for Izuku whenever he came out of the bathroom, slightly opening his legs to tease what was underneath.

This is so fucking cheesy, Katsuki mentally complained. *But the nerd is fucking obsessed with this—*

"Kacchan?" Izuku called loudly.

He hopped on his crutches down the pathway of rose petals to the dimly lit living room. His eyes were large as saucers, and his mouth hung open, slightly agape. He was wearing the white silk robe Katsuki had left for him and his curls were damp.

Katsuki perked up and carded his hands through his hair. He tried his best to act natural but found it very hard with the rose in his mouth.

"Wh-What is all this?" Izuku asked as he finally drew near. The light danced across his face, making his freckles more pronounced. "This…This is exactly—this is the same as—"

"—Yes, it's the same as your book," Katsuki mumbled. He took the rose out of his mouth and twirled it around, catching Izuku's attention with the small motion. "It's the scene after the mountain passage when they finally make it home. I read it all. *Twice*." Katsuki's smirk widened. "I can see why you enjoy that part so much."

Izuku didn't say anything. He stood there, taking in the whole scene in front of him like he was in a dream. He slowly descended from his crutches down to Katsuki's level. Izuku touched a rose petal as if it was made of glass. He picked it up and stared at it.

Katsuki's stomach knotted at the lack of words.

"Do you like it?" Katsuki asked wearily. "If you don't I can put this all away, and we can go to bed—"

"—No, I really love this," Izuku whispered. His voice cracked on the ends, and his eyes were glossy. "Th-This is exactly how I pictured the scene. Everything is perfect, I-I can't believe you did this."

"I'm glad you like it," Katsuki said quietly. He licked his lips and reminded himself: *soft*. Be soft. He leaned in and placed a hand on Izuku's exposed thigh. He caressed the smooth skin with his thumb. "I…I would do this again if…it meant…seeing you smile."

Izuku's eyes softened.

"I thought you hated anything to do with romance?"

“I guess it’s different when it comes to you.”

Katsuki handed Izuku the white rose.

Izuku reached out for it, his ring glimmering in the dim light. He took it in his hands and gazed down at it. Izuku’s smile was so fragile.

“Thank you so much,” Izuku whispered. “This is the nicest thing anyone has done for me.”

Katsuki didn’t want to think about how that potentially made him sad.

He picked up the two wine glasses instead and handed one to Izuku. The other man chuckled and took the drink from him with a glint in his eyes. They sipped on it slowly, maintaining eye contact. The liquid moved down Katsuki’s throat easily and Izuku choked.

“What’s wrong?” Katsuki asked after swallowing.

Izuku wiped his mouth with the back of his hand. He started laughing and swirled the wine in the glass. “I don’t like the taste of red wine. I thought I would get used to it—but I guess I never have.”

Katsuki laughed from his stomach. Their chuckles mixed in a chorus of joy and Katsuki shook his head. He took a couple big gulps of his drink before taking Izuku’s in his hand. He set them aside and smirked.

“Let’s cut to the main part then,” Katsuki said with a hint of playfulness. “Not everything has to be done by the book.”

His accidental husband gripped the white rose tightly. Katsuki decided then to shift on the blankets and gripped Izuku’s waist. He drew him in closer and the heat in the room grew thicker.

“This is where the lovers intertwine,” Katsuki whispered as he pulled at the sash on Izuku’s waist, undoing it to fall open. “They lose their virginity to the other, and they take it really slow and become forever bonded.” Katsuki kissed the tattoo on Izuku’s collar. “In sickness.” Another small kiss. “And in health.” A caress of the skin. “Until death do they part.”

Izuku’s breathing quickened.

“Are you nervous again?” Katsuki muttered directly against Izuku’s lips. He smiled mischievously. “I promise I’ll make sure I’m gentle. I know how delicate virgins can be.”

“I’m not a virgin anymore,” Izuku quipped. “And I’m not delicate.”

“I know. But c’mon, let me enjoy this.” Katsuki chuckled lightly and stole another kiss. “Still can’t get over my handsome virginal husband who *waited* until marriage for me all these damn years.”

Izuku laughed lightly and reddened. “Katsuki. You’re making me feel embarrassed calling me your husband.”

“Do you not like being called that? Husband suits you.” He dropped his voice several octaves on purpose to make Izuku squirm. He looked down and could see Izuku’s breathing hitch and his erection prop to life ever so slightly. Katsuki grinned wide. “You *really* fuckin’ seem like you’re enjoying it.”

“I-I am,” Izuku whispered like he was teetering on the edge of a forbidden line. Their eyes met and a burning intensity interlocked between them. “But, you don’t think it’s odd considering we are legally married by accident? It feels taboo to use it like this.”

“We’re alone, who will judge us?” Katsuki questioned. He snaked a hand underneath Izuku’s robe to teasingly rub the inside of the soft, freckled thigh.

“No one,” Izuku said breathlessly.

“Exactly.” Katsuki’s fingers snuck in closer to Izuku’s erection and he could feel the tension build between them like wildfire. He leaned in and softly nipped Izuku’s neck. “If you like it, I can call you my husband in bed.” He brushed their noses together. “This is between us, it’s private and intimate. You’re my *darling* husband right now and I’m yours.”

Izuku nodded hesitantly and closed his eyes.

His body loosened all the way as he fell into Katsuki’s temptation. He dropped the rose off to the side and wrapped his arms around Katsuki’s neck. They kissed deeply, tongues sliding across each other sweetly.

“Try saying it,” Katsuki said into the kiss. “Call me your husband.”

“Y-You’re my husband,” Izuku whispered back.

“And I’m going to take such good fucking care of you tonight,” Katsuki rasped hungrily. “*Bakugou* Izuku.”

Katsuki thought they were simply playing this out by the book, giving into a small sexual fantasy that Izuku had. However, the blurred line between reality and pretend between them was breached by acknowledging their title: *Husbands*.

He kissed Izuku harder as he thought about this—trying to will away the creeping thoughts. Katsuki could feel his chest expand, filling up with all the essence of whatever always sparked between them.

It was heavy, powerful, and called to him to keep pressing closer and closer. Izuku’s tongue slid against his as they drew in more, arms locked around each other. Katsuki took a hand and slowly slid it underneath the elegant fabric of Izuku’s robe.

He trailed his kisses down Izuku’s neck as he kneaded the soft skin under his fingertips. Izuku bared his neck, allowing small nips and kisses to be planted delicately on his skin. Katsuki tried his best to remember how soft the book described the intimacy and smiled when Izuku’s breath caught.

Fingernails dug into his shoulders as he grazed a perked nipple.

Katsuki pulled back and smirked. He pushed down the robe off Izuku's shoulders and exposed his heaving chest.

"You look so gorgeous right now," Katsuki said with a subtle rasp.

Izuku was sitting perfectly awaiting him, green eyes heavy and hazy. Katsuki licked two of his fingers and coated them well with his mouth. He reached back to the nipple and tweaked it slightly. Izuku bit his lip and fluttered his eyes. Katsuki pulled him in again, kissing him tenderly as he toyed with the nub in his hand.

Izuku's lips were softer than normal, he thought privately.

He gripped his fingers into Izuku's skin and slowly laid him down. He placed Izuku's head on one of the pillows that was decorated with endless patterns of gold and rose petals.

Big, green eyes stared up at him and he slowly raked his hand down Izuku's body. Katsuki planted one kiss, two kiss, three kisses along Izuku's jaw line as he parted the white robe, exposing his body.

Izuku's delicate hands moved up as well and pushed the black robe off Katsuki's shoulders. The fabric slid off his skin like sweet water and Izuku undid the sash from around his waist. The rope fell open and Katsuki grinned. He shrugged off the rest of it, embracing the warmth of the fire radiating on his bare skin.

Katsuki leaned in and laid kisses down Izuku's torso, massaging his sides as he dipped his head lower and lower. He stopped right above Izuku's cock and sucked lightly on the tip as he reached for the lube off to the side. Tiny gasp of pleasure fell out of Izuku's mouth with the new sensation.

Katsuki snapped his eyes up, curious to watch Izuku come undone.

The other man's eyes were screwed shut, and his hands were clawing at his stomach like he was trying to push out the sensation from his core. His mouth looked so cute, hung open as so many tiny moans spilled out of them. Katsuki took more of Izuku into his mouth, loving the way his husband lifted his hips to push into his mouth.

Katsuki uncapped the lube quietly and sucked harder, making Izuku groan deeply.

Small shudders and tremors quaked through Izuku as the fire snapped in the background. Intricate shadows danced across the planes of freckled skin and Katsuki coated his fingers with the thick lubricant.

He drew his head up, a long trail of silva bridged from his lips to the tip of Izuku's cock.

Pretty pink blush blended with the orange light on Izuku's skin and Katsuki wished he could burn this visual of the enchanting man into the back of his mind. Gorgeous, half lidded green eyes were entirely dilated. Izuku was laid bare with everything on display—scars, wounds, and freckles all mixing together like a painting.

The heated stare Izuku was giving him was loaded with so many unspoken words. Shyly, Izuku opened his legs. He parted all the way for Katsuki and lifted his hips. He reached down and pulled apart his cheeks to give the perfect fucking view of his pretty hole.

Katsuki slid one finger in and Izuku's breath caught.

Katsuki licked his lips, arousal ignited as his finger was hugged tightly. Izuku held his grip on his cheeks as the finger slid in more and more until his knuckle was hit.

Egged on to get more reaction, Katsuki searched straight for Izuku's sweet spot, making the other man tremble. Katsuki pushed at it again, sliding another finger in. Izuku's legs quaked, and Katsuki bit his lip when the deep need inside of his core was telling him to make Izuku come undone even further.

Katsuki's free hand began pumping Izuku's cock in tandem with the jolts against his prostate. Izuku gasped in shock at the double intrusion of pleasure, hands slipping to grapple at the blankets below them and grasping rose petals too.

A satisfied grin spread across Katsuki's sharp features when he could see the euphoria take Izuku.

He fucked his two fingers in and out gently, watching how Izuku's chest rose and fell with every beat of pleasure he was given. Beads of sweat gathered on both of their brow lines, as the temperature in the room spiked to new heights.

"I should've taken you from the front last time," Katsuki said huskily. He added a third finger and squeezed the base of Izuku's cock. Ripples of pleasure gathered at the bottom of his core from seeing Izuku's doll face be overcome with rapture. "Your expressions are so damn gorgeous."

He stroked Izuku quicker and added a fourth finger. Izuku rocked with his motions, heels digging into the plush blankets. His back arched with every push and pull of ecstasy. Katsuki's breath caught higher and higher in response to Izuku's. He was fully mesmerized as Izuku's moans transformed into cries of pleasure as he fingered his husband harder and jerked his cock in sync.

Izuku didn't give any warning, voice breaking down to pure syllables of his lover's name.

The way Izuku came this time was art in motion.

His mouth dropped, sweat rolled down his face and chest. His legs gave underneath the powerful electricity that rocked his nerves and his hole clamped down on the wet fingers stuffing him. He shuddered vehemently and rose petals stuck to his dampened skin. His cum sprayed across both of them, and Katsuki's heartbeat quickened when a droplet caught on his chin.

He slid his fingers out and then leaned down and gave a gentle kiss to the inside of Izuku's thigh.

The other man jolted slightly, laughing in surprise. Katsuki raised a brow.

“Ah, wait, that tickles,” Izuku said. His chest was rising and falling quickly, and his toes were curled from the leftover waves of his orgasm.

“Really?” Katsuki smiled against the area and kissed it again. He toyed with it a bit, lightly touching it with his hand. Izuku began giggling under the touch and squirming. “Holy fuck. I think I found a spot on you.”

“A spot?”

“Mhm,” Katsuki hummed, delighted. “An area that’s more sensitive than others. Only a couple people have them.” He tickled the area a bit more, and Izuku laughed again. “You’re so cute.”

When he could sense Izuku relax all the way he slid his hand upwards and added more lube to Izuku’s stretched out backside.

He pushed in lightly, and Izuku’s laughter faded into a soft gasping. He played around with Izuku a bit, drawing out all the tiny groans and teasing him back up. Izuku’s cock twitched back to life slowly as Katsuki took his time to work him into pleasure once more. When the tiny gasps were now whines accompanied by withering, Katsuki sat back on his hunches.

He stroked himself well, slicking his cock up while keeping his eyes trained on Izuku.

At his core, the unnamed feeling had its mouth wide open, feeding on every moment that was occurring. Every glance, touch, smile and even the smell of roses was direct fuel in the pit in his heart.

Katsuki leaned over and gripped Izuku’s hips firmly.

They locked eyes and butterflies tickled in his stomach all the way up his ribcage. He spread his legs as he pulled Izuku into his lap. He picked him up, and they came face to face and heart to heart. The pounding in both of their chests vibrated through the other.

Suddenly, all Katsuki wanted was to be closer.

They never took their eyes off the other as Katsuki aligned his cock with Izuku’s wet entrance.

Slowly, Katsuki lowered Izuku down on him, stretching his hole with every inch deeper and deeper. They breathed out together as they melted into one. Izuku gripped onto his shoulders until his knuckles turned white.

Katsuki groaned and bit his lip as he was wrapped in Izuku’s wet, velvety hole. It sucked him in and he buried his face into the crook of Izuku’s neck. He hugged Izuku closely, holding him in his lap. The heat from the fire, their bodies, and the fog in his mind melded together.

He moved slowly once he buried himself to the hilt.

Izuku gasped and they began to rock together as steady as a gentle ocean.

The push and pull they created was nothing like Katsuki had felt before.

All around him was Izuku as he moved: his dewy skin was softer than the flower petals scattered across the floor and his breathing was beautifully rhythmic to their motions. Their movements became more sensual, and Katsuki pushed against Izuku's prostate with purpose. Izuku groaned deep in the back of his throat as he ground down.

"Do you like it soft like this?" Katsuki asked.

"I do," Izuku replied. "Do you like it too?"

Katsuki smiled into Izuku's neck and breathed him in. "I like it a whole lot. Am I doing this right?"

"Y-Yeah, please—keep going."

Katsuki's heart swelled with validation.

They kept going like this, indulging in each other with soft whispers of encouragement and affection. The pleasure gained momentum as they continued, drowning the other in intimacy that they didn't think was possible. Katsuki stared up at Izuku, trying to think when he ever fucking felt this intense while being inside of someone.

He searched for an answer and was met with the blunt fact: Only Izuku made him feel like this.

For the first time Katsuki really did believe he could be soft—for as long as Izuku was around.

"You're so beautiful," Katsuki whispered. "I could do this with you all damn night."

Izuku stroked a shaky hand down the hills of Katsuki's arm and gripped tight. "Me too."

Katsuki sweetly kissed Izuku's skin, counting every freckle with each deep thrust. Then a shower of kisses rained onto his face as Izuku began moaning desperately. Every soft touch was more loaded than any rough motion he was used to. Katsuki groaned as his eyes closed at the tender flutter of kisses and his body heat coiled tightly.

For the first time, Katsuki felt *wanted*.

Katsuki hugged Izuku closer and rocked harder, pushing out more sharp cries.

He started moving deeper, grinding up and soaking himself in pleasure. He stared up at Izuku's blissed out face the whole time, watching those wonderful expressions as his cock was squeezed. Wet, squelching sounds breached his ears with Izuku's whimpering. He grinned through his panting and fucked upwards harder, bouncing Izuku in his lap.

Izuku whined as Katsuki quickened the motions. He wantonly rolled his hips and Katsuki nearly lost his mind.

“Kacchan, I feel so cl-close again—*aah*—I’m n-not going to last.”

Powerful ecstasy pulsed in his cock. Katsuki didn’t want this feeling of belonging to end.

Katsuki reached between them to grip the base of Izuku’s dripping cock. A sharp cry dribbled out from Izuku’s mouth as Katsuki snapped his hips upwards in a powerful motion, bouncing the smaller man. Katsuki’s thumb smeared the droplets of pre-cum oozing out from Izuku’s slit.

“Have I ever told you how pretty you are?” Katsuki asked breathlessly. “These freckles.” Thrust. “Those eyes.” Thrust. “Your voice.” He ground his hips to punctuate his sentence. “My darling husband is breathtaking.”

He squeezed the throbbing length in his hand as he bounced Izuku on his cock. Izuku’s head bobbed furiously as he gripped on tightly for balance.

“Do you feel how much I want you?” Katsuki asked with hunger in his voice.

“Yes, aah, I feel it, I feel you—I want you too. I want you so much too.”

“Ye-Yeah,” Katsuki panted. His eyes dilated fully in the dim light. The chord inside of his belly tightened more with every deep thrust. His mind clouded as his orgasm built. He glanced down at the green gem on his ring finger and back up to the shining eyes that matched it in color. “Y-You’re mine, right?”

“Mhmm,” Izuku moaned. His eyes fluttered closed, and his body began to seize up.

Katsuki was unsatisfied with that answer. He squeezed the base of Izuku’s cock. “Be more specific, darling, if you want to cum.”

Izuku’s brows pinched together, giving an outcry of pleasure. “I-I—*ah. Fu-fuck.*”

“Say it.” Katsuki sneered. “Are you *mine*?”

He needed to hear it. *Fuck*. He needed to hear it so damn bad—

“I’m *yours*,” Izuku answered in a single breath. “I’m your husband—”

Katsuki groaned deeply as he started thrusting harder. Every jolt added a hot sensation into his core as he breathed in Izuku’s cries. Their motion drew out combinations of emotions Katsuki didn’t even know were possible. Affection blended with pleasure. Adoration mixed with need. Absolute desolation blurred with want.

Izuku cried out his name in a broken moan and arched like a perfect bow. He came harshly into Katsuki’s fist, causing the liquid to seep through Katsuki’s fingers.

Katsuki's vision pulsed, and his hips thrusted once, then twice until he seized up. His orgasm ripped through him with enough force for him to bite into Izuku's freckled shoulder. He came deep inside of the other man, filling Izuku to the brim with everything he had.

Katsuki's chest heaved as he kept Izuku trapped in his arms.

Izuku's breath was steadying as they allowed time to be still around them. Eventually, Izuku ran a hand through Katsuki's hair, drawing his attention.

Katsuki looked at the smaller man in his lap, wordlessly. Tiny rose petals were sticking to both of their skin and for once—Katsuki thought it was romantic in a nice way.

"That was so amazing," Izuku mumbled.

Izuku's hands intertwined with Katsuki's, not letting go. He laid a simple kiss on top of Katsuki's wedding band.

Emotions thumped around Katsuki's chest cavity at the sight. Everything was heightened to the extreme and all he could think about was Izuku. Izuku. *Izuku*.

He was a little too stunned to speak right away. Instead, he nodded dumbly as his high carried through his limbs. The come down gave him enough clarity to understand that he's never felt that intensity before. He had no clue that going soft and deep in that way elicited the burning in his chest. It scratched at him, begging for more.

What the hell was Izuku *doing* to him?

"Did you like it soft like that?" Katsuki eventually asked. "I tried my best to make sure I was gentle."

"I did, that was different in a good way," Izuku said happily.

"I can keep doing that for you, if you enjoy it more than me being rough." Katsuki smiled and drew tiny hearts on Izuku's skin. "I should've done this for your first time and made you feel all special and shit."

"I liked it the way we did it before too," Izuku clarified. He squeezed Katsuki's hand in his reassuringly. "I wouldn't have changed how I had my first experience because I had it with you. That's all I really wanted, Kacchan. I don't mind either way as long as your lips are on mine."

Katsuki's heart skipped a beat. "Really?"

"Mhm." Izuku grinned. "I especially like it when your hands are on me—" Izuku paused and guided Katsuki's hand up to his throat. He assisted in clasping the large fingers tightly around his throat until it was a near perfect necklace. "—*like this*. I have more than one type of fantasy but they're all involving *you*."

Katsuki's cock twitched a bit knowing that. The selfish side of him was happy. He was the only one to ever experience this side of Izuku, and even better he was who Izuku fantasized

about. He wondered how long Izuku had seen him in this light and even more so he wondered if Izuku had ever touched himself to the thought of him.

“What else have you been interested in?” Katsuki asked carefully, not removing his hand.

Izuku bit his lip shyly, clearly embarrassed about what he was about to say next. “…Have you ever heard of edging?”

A dark, sharp chuckle escaped from Katsuki. He gave a depraved smile and happily choked Izuku lightly, pulling him by his neck to draw his lips close.

“We’re about to have *a lot* of fucking fun. Aren’t we?”

Izuku nodded and raked his nails down Katsuki’s back. They shared another heated kiss as Katsuki clasped his hand firmer while moving their lips together. He could feel the pulse of Izuku’s heart under his fingertips as their kiss deepened.

He laid Izuku down on his back in the sea of rose petals and they were lost to each other the rest of the night.

☽ ☽ ☽

Two full weeks passed after the moment they shared in front of the fireplace, and Katsuki had never felt more gratified.

Izuku didn’t have a preference for soft or rough—his only preference was Katsuki. Which did something to Katsuki’s brain chemistry, he was damn sure of it. Knowing that Izuku liked him wholly as he was with no changes was an experience he never encountered.

Izuku really did like him for *him*.

But little did either of them know, that single moment was the turning point for a floodgate of intense craving to be opened. Katsuki assumed that it was sexual need at the root of it, but he knew it was a lot more than carnal desire that made him so hungry for Izuku.

“I’m yours.”

Those two words stuck to his brain and grew deep roots. After that, it was damn near impossible to keep his hands off Izuku. They had sex in the bedroom, in the hallway and in the bathroom. It didn’t stop there, however. Soon they were fucking in the living room. Next, the pottery room and the brand-new music room after his lessons.

Hell, some days they even went at it in the kitchen.

“My tea is really hot,” Izuku said one day. His hand was under the table creeping straight towards Katsuki’s belt buckle. “Maybe we should…wait for it to cool down?”

What a poor fucking excuse—and Katsuki took it.

“Wouldn’t want you to burn your pretty tongue,” Katsuki answered cheekily. “I really would like to keep that part of you in good shape.” His eyes danced to Izuku’s plump lips. “Have you ever sucked cock before, darling?” Izuku shook his head and his eyes dilated. “Well. That’s a damn shame. I guess it’s time to learn.”

He unbuckled his belt and guided Izuku down onto his knees.

After that nothing really could stop them. There was even one day they found themselves on the porch just fucking raw out in the open. That was one of Katsuki’s favorite times, the smell of after rain mixed with Izuku’s natural scent was like a goddamn drug.

Izuku’s moans were soon his favorite song. But most of all, Katsuki was beginning to be addicted to the new pet name kink they unlocked.

“Katsuki,” Izuku’s breathy voice would groan as he was taken from the back. “M-Make me scream, I wanna cum for my husband.”

So. Fucking. Perfect.

Katsuki couldn’t get enough of Izuku, and it was very well reciprocated. Their newly reached intimacy fed into that unnamed emotion of his to the point it was growing more and more hungry with every passing day. It was insatiable.

Every single bit of Izuku Katsuki wanted until he could consume him whole.

It worried him a bit, how much he wanted to keep tasting Izuku. They had said they would part ways after Izuku’s ankle healed—but could he really let Izuku go again when the time came?

Katsuki was beginning to doubt himself because every time he heard *‘husband, please’* in that sensual voice, his logic was left at the door. His eyes wandered to their matching rings, and this made the unnamed feeling inside of Katsuki feel like it was rotting. He considered this to be because of something Sero told him.

Once upon a time, his worry wart colleague preached that sex was something intimate.

He remembered how Sero went on for an hour about how he and Denki were potentially putting their fucking *souls* at risk by making so many bonds with random strangers. Sero warned him that one day he would screw around and make a bond that would cause him to be distressed and Katsuki thought he was full of bullshit.

Well, he thought that until right now—because like Izuku said, maybe all it took was the right person.

Potentially, a person who was currently on his back for him, whimpering.

“Ha-Harder!” Izuku cried out for the nth time. “Please, Ka-Kacchan! Deeper! *Deeper*!”

Beads of sweat were rolling down Katsuki’s back and forehead as he tried to keep up the impossible pace they set. He was driving into Izuku on their bed, rocking the frail piece of

furniture into the wall without mercy. He snapped his hips into the smaller man, who was trembling under him. Izuku's wrists were pinned against the mattress as he spread his legs wide.

Katsuki gripped Izuku's wrists tighter when the pleasure built like a firecracker. He gritted his teeth as ripples of overpowering ecstasy stretched through him.

"I-I'm going to cum—" Izuku's words were swallowed by a cry and a gasp.

Fuck. Izuku's moans were so goddamn *addictive*.

Izuku's body seized up, arching all the way into Katsuki. Ribbons of white cum spilled between them and tiny bits reached Katsuki's lips. He licked the sweet cum up eagerly as he gave several deep rolls of his hips, forcing Izuku to shiver with pleasure once more. The wetness surrounding his cock squeezed him deliciously, drawing his own orgasm out of him.

Katsuki groaned loudly as he buried himself all the way to the hilt and came deep inside of Izuku. He rushed to capture Izuku's lips and he pushed his tongue inside Izuku's mouth, tasting all the bits and pieces of him as he moaned loudly.

They broke apart, panting heavy and still connected in more ways than one.

Twin grins broke across both their faces, and Katsuki could have sworn he was fucking drunk on endorphins.

They laid there, cooling down and Katsuki hadn't moved a bit. He knew he should let Izuku's wrists go, but Izuku seemed perfectly content being captured. But the second the sun caught on the ruby gem on Izuku's finger, Katsuki exhaled roughly.

He let go of his husband's slender wrists and slid out of him to lay beside him. Izuku automatically turned inwards like a magnet being pulled to curl into him. Katsuki wrapped his arms around him and they closed their eyes.

"You've been cooped up here for a while," Katsuki muttered in a groggy voice. He caressed Izuku's curls. "Aren't you getting restless?"

"I'm happy here," Izuku whispered back in a gentle tone without opening his eyes. "We go to your music lessons and the estate is very large. I don't feel cooped up at all."

Katsuki pursed his lips. "What if we go somewhere?"

"Where?"

"Anywhere."

"Kacchan, you have to be a little more specific."

"I don't have anywhere in mind," said Katsuki with a shrug. "But don't you think it would be fun to go to a nice restaurant? We could dress up really fancy and shit. Make it a night out and everything."

Izuku smiled against his skin. “That sounds nice. But your definition of dressing fancy is wearing deeper shades of black.”

Katsuki laughed. “You’re right but it’s a very nice shade of black. You’re underestimating it.”

“Possibly. I think you would look nice in orange though,” Izuku said sleepily. His words dragged slightly as his breathing evened out. “It would pop the color of your eyes. You have really vibrant, red eyes that lean towards orangish. But it’s very subtle…you would miss it if you’re not looking closely.”

“Sounds like you enjoy staring into my eyes, darling.”

“Always.”

A soft snore followed that single word. Katsuki opened his eyes to see Izuku drifting off to sleep while holding on to him. Katsuki’s chest was coated with warmth, and he smiled fully content. He twirled a lock of Izuku’s hair around his finger while studying the various pretty freckles up close.

Orange, huh?

☽ ☽ ☽

The next day the two of them went to the mall together.

Katsuki didn’t tell Izuku it was because he wanted to try out new clothes, so instead he let it be a surprise. Despite every fucking fiber of his fashion taste telling him to go straight for the dark colored sweaters, Katsuki reached for the oranges and reds. He brought the clothes into the dressing room and tried on one particular orange sweater that hugged his arms nicely.

When he emerged from the dressing room, Izuku’s eyes bulged so wide he thought they were going to pop out. His jaw dropped and he sat all the way up. Katsuki tried his best not to feel ridiculously self-conscious.

“So, what do you think?” Katsuki asked with a knowing grin. He did a full circle turn with his hands up. He shot Izuku a handsome grin and was more than happy to see Izuku flustered and blushing. “I’m guessing you like it.”

“I-It looks great on you,” Izuku complimented in his daze. His eyes refused to leave Katsuki. “You look amazing in orange. You should try out reds too, I think those would look great on you.”

Katsuki’s heart sped up like he was running a marathon at the approval.

He let Izuku pick out a handful of clothes after that.

Soon, he didn’t mind wearing reds and oranges as the weeks passed.

☽ ☽ ☽

With each passing day, they found something new to do when he didn't have his music class.

The days didn't feel like days anymore. Hours were nothing but laughter. Minutes were crunched down to tiny glances and small kisses. Even the seconds were cradled down to tiny specks in time that were filled with a type of bliss Katsuki never truly imagined was possible.

He had finally felt fulfilled for once in his life, and if he couldn't break the hands on Fate's clock, then he would ignore them and fill the space with as many moments as he could.

The first thing they decided on was going out to a string of nice restaurants. Each day of the week they tried a different genre of food: Seafood. Pasta. Traditional. Vegetarian.

They tasted as many dishes as they could together over candle lit dinners. The romantic lighting made Izuku appear so sweet. His green curls were bouncy, and his doll-like face was so perfectly framed by his hair. Somehow, Izuku appeared to be an entirely different person, or maybe it was just the setting.

Katsuki was having a hard time really telling what the difference was, but damn. *Something* was different. Izuku's smile was shier recently too and he always wanted to hold his hand, not that Katsuki minded. He held it back just as eagerly and rarely was inclined to let it go.

After that, they settled for touring a couple of the neighboring towns.

By this time, Izuku's ankle was healing properly. They had reached the two month and a half mark, and Izuku was able to put a bit of weight on the injury. Seeing Izuku nearly walk that day in the park under the autumn leaves gave Katsuki a sense of joy, but also anxiety. He wearily stared at their wedding rings as Izuku tested out how much weight he could lean on that leg.

Katsuki's stomach tightened at the sight. He wasn't entirely sure that he liked Izuku healing.

Then another moment they shared was the day they traveled down to Nara.

Katsuki particularly enjoyed this day. He caught a cute photo of Izuku feeding a deer at the same time a small butterfly landed on his nose. It was adorable beyond belief—and it was his new phone background. He did it privately, but he enjoyed the gleeful twinkle in Izuku's face every time he looked at his phone.

Katsuki found himself smiling at his phone a lot, still ignoring all texts and calls.

☽ ☽ ☽

Three months had passed and the leaves on the trees were the same shade of orange as the dusk sky.

These were now his and Izuku's favorite moments.

They would sit on the porch together and watch the entire landscape slowly become painted in hundreds of shades of orange. The leaves. The sun. The sky. Anything the light touched

was basked in the golden radiance, including them. Katsuki would lay his head on Izuku's lap during these still mornings. Tiny hands stroked through his hair as his face slowly warmed up.

He closed his eyes as this happened, enjoying the gradual comfort against his skin.

When he cracked open his eyes, usually he only saw the canopy of trees. However, this day, he opened his eyes and saw Izuku's doll face eclipsing the sun. Behind him were leaves ranging from golden yellow, orange, and bright red. The gentle breeze blew in, sending a perfect chill down both of their bodies.

Emotion filled viridian eyes were gazing down at him, pouring out unspoken affection.

Izuku was mesmerizing, was all Katsuki could really think.

This was truly a sight he could get used to.

"Enjoying your retirement so far?" Izuku asked tenderly.

"More than you could imagine," Katsuki muttered. "This is the most relaxed I've been, ever."

"Good. You deserve it."

How sweet. Katsuki smiled up at Izuku and tilted his head.

He hadn't considered that this potentially was what the rest of his life would be like.

When he gave it some thought, he really did think he could get used to this, if the last three months were any indication of his future. Waking up every day to a damn cute face, listening to Izuku's humming and hearing him giggle over his books. All the kisses and hugs. He could even see himself filling his new room with music sheets as Izuku played his song on the violin in the background—

—Then reality slammed into him.

It was as brutal as a fist to the face and it punched the grin right off his lips.

Izuku's smile faltered briefly, and the wind blew his shirt to show his '217' tattoo. Izuku leaned down and kissed Katsuki's forehead. Then he averted his gaze off to where the sun was slowly pulling itself into the blue sky.

But Katsuki couldn't look away from the tattoo even if he tried.

He attempted to picture his retirement without Izuku—but his mind drew a blank. A very large Izuku shaped blank because he wasn't used to retirement, he was used to *Izuku*.

That unnamed emotion churning inside of him yelled until white noise filled his ears.

Then it clicked at what it might be—and the thought terrified Katsuki more than any man or monster he ever encountered.

☽ ☽ ☽

The next day, Katsuki could tell Izuku was slightly anxious.

After drinking his poison, Izuku tested out how well his foot could hold up his weight and he was adjusting his cast every couple of minutes. Katsuki felt frustrated with their circumstances, but most of all he was frustrated with himself. It turned out, ignoring the world didn't stop time no matter how much one begged and pleaded.

He hadn't thought of a plan to keep Izuku here, and he had no idea how to even begin to propose that. But he was officially almost out of borrowed time.

Izuku's ankle was nearly healed, and Katsuki was considering breaking it again.

Katsuki had gone to sleep that night wondering, what *were* they going to do once the cast was off?

He had never liked anyone before and had them like him *back*. He was plagued by thoughts regarding what Koizumi had revealed before he slit his throat. There was not a chance in hell Katsuki could let Izuku go back to whatever fucking academy he was raised in.

Izuku was trafficked. Fucking trafficked and forced into this type of goddamn life—just like Katsuki in a sense. They both had normal lives robbed from them in different ways, and he felt weirdly connected with Izuku—more than he already did—because of it. Izuku was just like him. He wasn't supposed to be dripping in red either, yet here they were, both with enough unspeakable sins to fill a graveyard.

As he watched Izuku drift peacefully off to sleep that night, Katsuki decided that he needed to figure something out.

He didn't know *what* yet, but he would figure it out.

☽ ☽ ☽

The following day Izuku was patiently watching the TV as he waited for Katsuki to round the corner. He had been told to sit still and wait for a surprise that Katsuki put together, and in the back of the estate Katsuki bustled around, trying his best to ignore everything until he possibly could.

"Kacchan?" Izuku called out impatiently. "What are you doing back there?"

"Just sit tight will ya," Katsuki grumbled. "I'll be out in a minute!"

Katsuki huffed and fixed his burnt orange turtleneck. He leaned over the cake that was in front of him. He double checked it again, making sure it was the exact order he asked the bakery for. It was a three-tier vanilla cake with strawberries and chocolate drizzled along the sides. The various layers had different types of cookie crumbles spread across the tops.

It all appeared really fucking delicious, but Katsuki's favorite part was the frosting writing that read 'Happy birthday, Izuku!'. Katsuki grinned and picked up the cake. He walked into

the kitchen extremely slowly, balancing the heavy pastry with expert agility.

“Happy birthday, you fucking nerd,” Katsuki announced with a lopsided smirk.

Izuku whipped his head around and a small, baffled grunt caught in his throat. Katsuki held up the cake and Izuku nearly fell out of his chair from confusion.

“B-Birthday?” Izuku parroted. His nose scrunched and his hands curled into himself. “Kacchan, it’s November. My birthday is in July.”

Katsuki chuckled, amused and ignored the comment. He sat down the cake carefully in front of the bewildered man. Then he quickly reached behind him and exposed the bright green sash that read ‘Happy Birth!’ in big, white lettering.

“Yeah, yeah, I know when your damn birthday is,” Katsuki quipped. “In case you forgot, we have celebrated it before, and I have a decent memory sometimes.” He pulled the sash over Izuku’s head, watching how the other man fidgeted in the chair. “Now we get to have a second celebration together.”

Big, green eyes kept darting between him, the cake, and the sash.

“B-But why?” Izuku questioned, unsure. He stared at the cake like it shouldn’t be meant for him. “I don’t really understand why you’re—wh-why you’re doing all of this suddenly.”

Because I want to make you smile while I have time.

Because I want you to enjoy your rest here.

Because maybe I want you to stay.

“Because on your bucket list you wrote ‘have a birthday party’,” Katsuki reminded him, ignoring the way his heart was constricting. He took out a single candle from his pocket and a lighter. He lifted up the two items before sticking the candle on top of the cake. “I know it’s not the right day, but I figured this is the least I can do to make up for Tokyo. It was the last thing on your bucket list. We officially completed it.”

Katsuki lit the candle.

He turned to Izuku, and his grin was wiped off his face. Glassy green eyes stared at him, with tears threatening to fall.

“What are you crying for?” Katsuki asked as gently as he could. He sat down quickly, worried that he had pushed this too far. “Is this too much?”

“Sorry,” Izuku sobbed slightly. He pressed his palms into his eyes and shook his head. “I-I’m sorry I didn’t mean to cry. I-I love everything.” Izuku removed his hands and stared at Katsuki once more. Emotion overcame him as he saw everything he ever wanted laying in front of him. “You got the cake I like, the sash, a-and—” Izuku hiccuped lightly. He wiped away more tears furiously. “You got me everything I-I put on my dumb list.”

Katsuki reached and grabbed Izuku's hands. "Of course I did. Now, blow out your candle and make a wish—that is, if you have one. Do you have something to wish for this time around?" Katsuki asked.

Izuku's smile was fragile again, threatening to fall and shatter. "I do have a wish this time."

Izuku breathed in and blew out the candle with an unreadable expression.

Katsuki hoped Izuku's wish was to stay.

Katsuki smiled and clapped lightly, and cheered, making Izuku laugh with a blush on his face. They cut the cake together, and Katsuki made sure to give Izuku the biggest piece he could possibly eat in one sitting. Music played in the background and two tiny birds chirped from the windowsill.

The day was running smoothly so far, and it perfectly led into Katsuki's phase two of the birthday party: presents.

He wandered into the bedroom and pulled out a box decorated in royal blue wrapping paper. There was a large red bow on it and a small tag that read 'For: Bakugou Izuku' in marker. He retrieved it from their shared closet on his side.

When he brought it out into the kitchen, excitement was visibly tingling all over Izuku's body. The other man clasped his hands together patiently and smiled with all his pearly white teeth.

Katsuki handed the box to Izuku, and the birthday man ripped it open.

"Books?" Izuku gasped. "Oh! *Romance* books!"

"Yup. By the same author of that really old one you carry around," Katsuki pointed out. He proudly leaned back as Izuku's eyes sparked to life. "Turns out they have a lot of new series out. I figured you've been too busy to ever look into the newer stories, but I got you all the recent ones so you can have a big ol' nerdy field day."

"This is exactly what I wanted." Izuku cried more, but this time he was smiling. "Thank you so much, Kacchan. Ah, I can't wait to read these. I-Is it okay if I look through a couple of them now? Just too skim!" The excitement in his voice was palpable.

"Go crazy, darling," Katsuki encouraged.

Izuku squealed slightly and began thumbing through all the fresh pages.

Katsuki watched him as he did this, and the rest of the morning was spent listening to Izuku geek out. Katsuki propped his chin on his fist as he observed Izuku in his natural habitat.

The way Izuku's eyes were full of nothing but joy was something to behold. Protect, even. Katsuki hung on to his every word as Izuku explained the intricacies of the older book's plot that he really couldn't exactly follow without reading himself, but Izuku was having fun explaining it to him.

But as he watched Izuku be, well, Izuku, Katsuki's chest hurt once more. That unnamed feeling he feared he finally identified returned tenfold. It made him worry. Katsuki glanced outside at the window at the autumn leaves and sucked in a deep breath.

"Izuku," Katsuki interrupted. Izuku perked up, nose out of one of the novels. "In your romance books, how did the characters know they were in love?"

"Ah, it happens gradually," Izuku answered easily. He drew invisible circles on the table as he smiled. "There's never a moment where the character declares they start loving the other person. They slowly start to realize little things or cues as they fall progressively in love."

Katsuki's leg jittered. "Tell me. What are the cues?"

"How come?" Izuku questioned innocently. "Are you interested in the books now too?"

"Something like that," Katsuki murmured. He leaned in close to Izuku and gave him his full attention. "Maybe I was wrong about romance being bullshit and all. The bit of the book I did read was really great and we had a lot of fun afterward, hm? Maybe I need to be more open minded."

Izuku grinned wide, and his eyes filled with admiration. He held up the new set of books in his hands like he was a professor ready to give a speech in class.

"Well, usually the first sign is their heart speeds up around the other person."

Check.

"Then they look at the person in a new light. Almost like viewing them for the first time and how they can fit in their life in ways they didn't consider before."

Double check.

"And when they touch, they don't want to let go of them."

Triple check.

"Then finally, they can't imagine their life without them."

And that was the final confirmation Katsuki needed to realize what he feared: he was undeniably in love with Izuku.

Katsuki nodded, forcing his smile to remain taut on his face. "Thank you. That was helpful."

"Of course!" Izuku giggled. He hugged one of his books in a way that helped none of the hurting in Katsuki's chest. "If you want to talk more about the books, let me know. Maybe we can even read them together. You have a great read out loud voice."

"I might take you up on that offer, darling."

Katsuki smiled and so did Izuku.

Izuku eventually went back to his books, beginning to read the start of one. They moved from the kitchen area to the den. Izuku laid comfortably in his lap and Katsuki held him close the whole time. They draped a fluffy blanket over their bodies to counter the autumn chill in the air.

Katsuki tried to casually watch TV as Izuku read in his arms, but his mind couldn't budge. It was stuck on a single fact:

He was in love with Izuku.

His heart and head hammered in sync, finally on the same page with something. With a deep look of sorrowful longing, Katsuki watched how Izuku flipped through page after page. The nerd was far too deep in geeking out to notice Katsuki's inner turmoil that was burning like coals against his core.

It always has been Izuku, hasn't it? Katsuki thought curiously.

As kids, it was him. In Vienna, it was him. In Taiwan, it was him. As rivals, it was him. After his mother's death, it was him who distracted him well enough to live on. Somehow in Okinawa, it was him teaching him how to be soft. Even now, here in the small town of Biei—it was him who Katsuki wanted to spend all his time with.

All roads led to Izuku.

Ask him to stay, his reasoning suggested. *He likes it here. He should stay where he's happy.*

Katsuki nervously toyed with his ring. He cleared his throat and reached to take one of Izuku's hands. He noted how much smaller it was than his but still scarred the same.

Izuku stopped reading and glanced up at him. Katsuki searched Izuku's eyes and then his own heart for how to say what he needed to say.

However, before he could speak a word, abrupt violent banging on his door occurred.

Both Izuku and Katsuki's heads whipped at the sudden sound and the banging grew louder and louder until it nearly sounded like the door cracked under pressure.

Chapter End Notes

Knock knock, whose there? Katsuki. Katsuki, who? Katsuki's last POV chapter is the next chapter :)

Thank you so much for reading!

Chapter 16: Grave

Chapter Summary

> Grave (Tempo): To play very very slow and solemn

Chapter Notes

> Welcome back to this choochoo train of angst! First up, thank you to the LOML, Luna, for betaing like always! She's perfect. Secondly, if you have the chance please do check out the songs ^^ I really love them this chapter and have been holding them excitedly in my gubby lil hands for this special chapter. Without further rambling, I hope you enjoy the chapter!
>
> **Warnings: Angst.**

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 16 — Grave

.

.

.

"*Bakugou*!" The last voice he thought he would fucking hear shouted through the door. "Bakugou, I saw your stupid ass hair's silhouette in the window. Open up, otherwise we're kicking this door down!"

"Shit," Katsuki hissed. "Shit. Shit. *Shit*."

He scrambled upright and Izuku did too.

Izuku stared at him confused, searching for an answer to what was happening.

"I know you hear me!" Monoma yelled again, a lot angrier. "You're going to open up on the count of ten and I am dragging you back to HQ if it's the last thing I do. I am tired of cleaning up your mess!"

"Who is that?" Izuku harshly whispered.

“It’s my fucking *coworker*,” Katsuki groaned.

Damnit. This was not an intrusion Katsuki planned upon.

He stared around at the scene in front of him and it was a *mess*. He tried his best to focus through the horrible banging that was in tandem with his drumming headache. Then the force Monoma was using grew more violent and Izuku clutched his book against his chest.

Shit.

Izuku.

“One,” Monoma started off. “*Two*—”

Katsuki shot up, grabbed Izuku and hoisted him in his arms. He didn’t listen to the small protest that was given to him when Izuku dropped his book.

“What are you doing?!” Izuku yelped.

“Hiding you,” Katsuki answered hastily.

His anxiety grew with every passing second Monoma counted. Katsuki quickly ran for the bedroom, and he went straight for the closet.

“Hiding me? Why are you *hiding* me?” Izuku questioned. His eyes were wide with bewilderment.

Katsuki swiftly opened the closet with his foot and dropped Izuku inside on the ground.

“Because—”

“—*Five*!” Monoma yelled impatiently. “*Six*!”

“Fuck,” Katsuki groaned. He scattered and grabbed two fist full of clothes off their hangers. He rapidly tossed them on top of Izuku in a poor attempt to conceal him. “I’ll explain later once I get them to go away. Stay here and don’t let them see you under any circumstance, okay?”

Izuku had a sock on top of his head, staring at him like he was crazy. “I can’t meet your coworkers?”

“—*Eight*!” Monoma called again. “You’re about to have to replace your door, Bakugou!”

Katsuki made a pained face. “No, you can’t meet this one. He isn’t exactly *friendly*.”

“*Nine*!” Monoma’s voice was close to shrill.

Izuku nodded quickly and fell in line. He grabbed a bunch of sweaters off their hangers and began piling them on himself until he was fully invisible to the untrained eye.

Once Izuku was simply a pile of sloppily organized clothes, Katsuki hauled off and ran towards the door. He cursed under his breath when he heard the sound of wood cracking.

“Ten!” Monoma screamed.

Katsuki opened the door in the nick of time and Monoma swung his leg into nothing.

The sheer force Monoma used cut through the air and created the sound of a whistle. Katsuki swiftly dodged the hit, thankful as all hell he did because the other blond’s strength really was his best quality as a hitman.

Slowly, Monoma recoiled and gritted his teeth and stood still.

Standing there waiting for him were Shinsou and Monoma, wearing polar opposite expressions. Both were dressed in normal attire, wrapped in scarves and early fall clothing. Monoma folded his arms and Shinsou gave a friendly wave.

“Well,” Katsuki said first, ignoring the heated glare being thrown at him. “Long time no see.”

“Keep your smart-ass remarks to yourself,” Monoma snapped. He pushed past Katsuki and marched into his home, bumping his shoulder along the way. “I’m so sick of you.”

Katsuki held back the insult he wanted to blurt out. The other blond walked into the open space of the living room and connected kitchen. He looked around suspiciously.

“Nice to see you’re well, Bakugou,” Shinsou greeted with a smirk. He walked in as well with relaxed posture and kindly patted Katsuki’s shoulder on the way in. “Glad to know you’re in one piece and not missing.”

“Yes, I’m perfectly fine,” Katsuki said a little testily. “How did you get my address?”

“You gave Aizawa the address to the estate after you inherited this place,” Shinsou reminded him. “He sent us to check on you while he’s busy managing.”

“We don’t want to be here either, trust me,” Monoma grumbled. He whirled on Katsuki with heated periwinkle eyes that might as well have been set on fire. “But you decided you don’t need to answer calls and now Aizawa is worried *sick* about you—which means he’s been worrying *us* sick. I could throw up looking at you right now.”

Katsuki scoffed at the melodrama and rolled his eyes.

“What Monoma is trying to say is you really left us all hanging,” Shinsou smoothed over. “It’s been three and half months since anyone has heard from you, and you never came back to wrap up. Y’know, to actually go into retirement you need to, oh…I dunno, *retire*?”

“I said I would do it once I’m set up,” Katsuki deflected.

“You look very well set up,” Monoma huffed. “What are you stalling for?”

“…Comfortability,” Katsuki half lied. “The estate needed time to get put together.”

Shinsou cocked his head and Monoma didn't seem like he believed a damn word. The other blond turned to survey the room and Katsuki spiked with nerves. He checked around and mentally cursed at the mess that was everywhere. It could pass as him living here alone but it could also pass as two people.

Then Monoma's eyes zoomed in on Izuku's book that was dropped on the ground.

"A *book*?" Monoma questioned. He picked up the novel by its corner and held it like it was infected with disease. "When have you ever read a book?"

"It's a new habit I'm picking up to stay literate," Katsuki shot back. He stalked up to Monoma and snatched the item from his coworker's grubby hands. "Look, you two can leave. Let the old man know I'm fucking *fine*. The Okinawa assignment took a lot out of me, and I wanted some time to myself."

"Trust me, I would *love* to do that, but Aizawa has his foot down our throats," Monoma explained. He flicked his wrist and kicked the blanket out of the way. "Where's your bathroom? I've been holding it in for hours trying to get to this town. It's a nice location, *very* far out of the way."

Katsuki ignored the sarcasm and pointed behind him. "Bathroom is the second door."

Monoma grunted and waddled off, unbuckling his belt as he went. When he rounded the corner, Shinsou was still standing near the doorway. He interrogatively glanced around as if he was trying to commit every detail to memory.

When Shinsou drew a little too close to the couch, Katsuki peeked his eyes downwards. He was happy he did because he saw a lone pair of frilly underwear discarded on the ground. He quickly kicked the garments under the couch before his colleague could notice.

Shinsou's eyes snapped towards him at the motion, and Katsuki played it off by stretching out his leg.

"Sorry," Katsuki awkwardly muttered. He stretched out the other leg in the same fashion. "Haven't moved around much all day. Need to get the joints greased up."

Shinsou's sharp eyes stared at him, giving no indication of emotions. Instead of entertaining Katsuki's strangeness, Shinsou jutted his chin at the dining table.

"Cake?" Shinsou questioned. "Since when did you have a sweet tooth?"

"I recently developed one," Katsuki fluidly answered.

"Interesting," Shinsou said slowly. He walked around the table and looked at the dirty dishes in the sink. He picked up one plate, and then cut his eye towards Katsuki. "Did you also recently develop a liking for the color orange too? I thought you only owned black."

"It's a good fall color. I wanted to try something new."

Shinsou put down the plate. "You're not here alone. Are you?"

Katsuki stiffened. He crossed his arms and pulled the corners of his mouth down into an intimidating scowl in an attempt to hide the truth. “Why do you think that?”

Shinsou raised a brow and tapped the side of his own neck.

Katsuki was confused until he mirrored the motion. When he touched his neck he realized that part of his skin was tender. He froze underneath the smirk that was slowly blooming on his colleague’s face.

Fuck. Izuku had left a hickey along his jaw last night.

Katsuki’s face grew redder by the passing second, and he pulled his turtleneck higher.

Shinsou’s smirk became smugger at every moment Katsuki floundered. He approached Katsuki with a stride that was arrogant like he had cracked some sort of difficult code. But despite his teasing nature, there was a subtle, unspoken kinship in his dark purple eyes.

“I get where you’re coming from if you want some…*down time*,” Shinsou said knowingly. “But it would be nice to come back to HQ and let everyone see you, don’t you think? One last goodbye. Aizawa won’t say it out loud, but he misses you. Put the old man out of his misery.”

“You’re right,” Katsuki said with a defeated sigh. “I guess I’ll come and close out as soon as possible.”

“Preferably today. Aizawa was convinced someone harmed you.”

“Who would harm me?” Katsuki’s face twisted in confusion.

“Oh, you know how he is,” Shinsou said nonchalantly. “He thought it might be Chizome, or even that mystery assassin you kept running into, the one you nicknamed ‘Deku.’ Aizawa showed everyone on the squad his picture by the way. He doesn’t look at all like I was expecting him to with how you described him.”

All the color drained from Katsuki’s face. “He showed a picture of Deku to M-Unit…?”

“Yeah, he wanted everyone to be aware. Mainly because you’re retiring, he even gave official kill orders to the rest of the unit.”

Katsuki swallowed. “Is a kill order really necessary since I’m not working anymore?”

Shinsou gave a hearty laugh. “Good one, Bakugou. It’s for the best, overall. He’s extremely dangerous from what Aizawa says and we don’t need some mystery assassin potentially up ending our assignments anymore. Plus, who is to say he doesn’t have kill orders on you too?”

Katsuki’s fists tightened while he restrained his face from showing any emotion. “Did Aizawa figure out his name?”

“No. Aizawa can’t locate his name, only a photo and some vague details but, that’s enough talk about him.” Shinsou’s grin spread wide. “Who’s the lucky guy you’ve been cozied up

with here? I can smell the honeymoon phase all over you—”

A loud crash interrupted their conversation and several gunshots.

Pumped full of immediate adrenaline, both Katsuki and Shinsou whipped their heads towards the violent disruption. Which erupted *directly* from the hallway with the bathroom and bedroom. Katsuki’s stomach dropped into a pit of despair within mere seconds. Then his worst nightmare came true when Izuku and Monoma stumbled out, viciously fighting each other.

Before anyone could make a move, Monoma whirled Izuku and hurled the smaller man to the ground with all his strength. Izuku winced, ankle cracking upon impact and he bit his lip as pain snapped through his body. Wasting no moment though, he scrambled to dodge two bullets that were shot at him.

Several things then happened at once.

Shinsou drew his gun, pointing it at Izuku. Izuku scrambled backwards on the floor, leg clearly damaged again and throbbing. Monoma reloaded and took aim once more—and placed his gun directly on Izuku’s forehead.

Then Katsuki bum rushed Monoma and brutally elbowed him in the face.

Shinsou’s eyes widened, and he was stunned into paralysis.

The bullets meant for Izuku’s skull whizzed past him and sank into the couch instead. Monoma groaned in pain as his head was snapped backwards by the inordinate force used. Blood splattered, but that didn’t stop Katsuki as he promptly disarmed Monoma and kicked him backwards on the ground. He finished reloading the gun and pointed it directly at Shinsou as he stood between Izuku and Shinsou’s line of fire.

Monoma and Shinsou both stared at Katsuki in horror.

“What are you doing, Bakugou?!” Monoma yelled furiously. He cupped his now broken nose, attempting to halt the profuse bleeding. “I found him hiding in your closet—”

“—And what were *you* doing in my goddamn bedroom?” Katsuki snapped. He walked back, stationing his body directly in front of Izuku on the ground. He didn’t take his sight off Shinsou who never lowered his gun away from Izuku. “You said you needed to use the bathroom.”

“I heard someone try to suppress a *sneeze*,” Monoma hissed and staggered upright. “And it turned out to be him! He’s trying to kill you—”

“—He’s not.” Katsuki cocked the gun. “He’s harmless.”

The tension in the room prickled like needles. Each stab punctured the four hitmen, and the pressure was suffocating as everyone surveyed each other. Monoma and Shinsou stood side by side in disbelief as Izuku slowly sat up on his hunches, entirely protected by Katsuki.

“Harmless?” Shinsou parroted cynically. “This is the same guy you said you would gladly torture if you got the chance. You even detailed how you would skin him alive and tear off his fingernails. Move aside so we can get this over with.”

“No. Back off.” Katsuki gritted his teeth and toyed with the trigger. “Point that gun elsewhere. *Now*. I’ll explain once you calm down.”

“You can’t be serious.” Shinsou tried to reason, not budging an inch. “Listen to me. This is clearly some type of ploy to *kill* you—”

“I *said* point the gun elsewhere,” Katsuki venomously warned.

“Bakugou. You’re *really* dancing the line here.”

“And I’ll dance right fucking over it in the next second if you don’t put your gun down.”

Silence stunned the room.

All eyes, including Izuku’s, were staring wide at Katsuki. But only one set of eyes was perceiving Katsuki with terrible realization.

Monoma’s gaze flickered from Katsuki to Izuku then back and forth again. Then slowly he narrowed in on the bruise along Katsuki’s jaw line, and the several on Izuku’s. He surveyed the living room, the fluffy blanket and the two cups on the coffee table. Then he glanced at the kitchen behind him towards the cake and the two dirty plates in the sink.

It came together quickly, and Monoma’s shoulders sagged. He sighed and grabbed the barrel of Shinsou’s gun. He slowly lowered it for his friend, who was now giving him a perplexed stare.

“They’re fucking,” Monoma said. He turned to Katsuki and looked him dead in the eye. “Aren’t you?”

Izuku wearily stared up at Katsuki and Katsuki wearily stared down at Izuku. Neither of them spoke, but their eyes translated a thousand sentences.

“*Oh*. You’ve got to be kidding me,” Monoma exasperated when he saw the lovesick stares Izuku and Katsuki were giving each other. He groaned and threw his head back. “You’re *more* than fucking. Of course. Nothing is ever simple with you.”

Shinsou was mortified. “Bakugou. Is that true?”

Katsuki lowered his gun and quietly helped Izuku off the floor. Izuku whimpered a little, lifting his ankle off the ground and leaned all the way into Katsuki. The pair exchanged long stares and Katsuki knew they screwed up on more than one count. But he was too far in to turn back now.

He wrapped his arm around Izuku’s midriff to balance him and turned back to his colleagues.

“We’re involved, yes.”

Monoma flew a hand up and turned around. Shinsou stared at him like he had grown a second head.

“This is debauched,” Shinsou accused. “You’re seriously trusting your dick to the guy who has tried to kill you for eight years?”

I married him, technically. Katsuki thought sarcastically. “He never tried to really kill me, and we’re officially done with all of that. Things between us are…complicated.”

“Cursed,” Monoma corrected. “Things between you are *cursed*.” He walked into the kitchen and shoved paper towels up his nostrils to collect the blood. “And what about Aizawa? Did you even stop and consider what would happen if he found out about this match made in hell? He’s going to beat your ass.”

It isn’t any of Aizawa’s damn business, is what Katsuki wanted to say. He was only alive right now because of Izuku’s kindness so long ago, and he would never hurt Izuku now that he knew who he was.

“This is why I haven’t called to check in,” Katsuki explained. “Him and I have figured out some stuff between us. It’s a lot to explain but Aizawa will understand once I tell it all.”

“No, Bakugou. He won’t.” This time Shinsou spoke. The look of eerie caution in his eyes was ignited high. “Aizawa understands a lot of things, but *this*—” He angrily waved his hand at Izuku. “—Will *not* be one of them. You weren’t there when he gave out the kill orders. Aizawa wants this *pest* dead for some other reason that he said he can’t disclose. This is no longer an issue between the two of you, it’s a company issue. Plus, he killed Rin Hiryu. How could you forgive him for that?”

Izuku stiffened. His defenses were through the roof. He was poised in a way that was partially behind Katsuki and his hand was curled into a fist, ready to strike.

“I’ll make him understand,” Katsuki said a bit too desperately. He held on to Izuku harder. “Once I explain it to him—”

“—If you explain anything to Aizawa, he will *kill* your homicidal boyfriend,” Monoma quipped. He wasn’t looking at any of them as he leaned over the sink. His shoulders crept up to his neck and he gripped the counter until his hands were white. “…Are you happy, Bakugou?”

No one expected the question.

Katsuki recoiled, and Shinsou turned his head towards Monoma at the strangeness. Izuku was wearily looking at Katsuki. Underneath the curious stare of those green eyes, Katsuki decided to let the answer roll off his tongue—consequences be damned.

“Yes. The happiest I’ve ever been.”

Monoma nodded silently. He strummed his fingers.

“Then you will keep this a secret,” Monoma forced himself to say. He turned around with an expression Katsuki had never seen woven on his features: understanding. However, he cut his eyes towards Izuku with intense distrust. “And we will keep this to ourselves too. If this shit runs into the ground then so be it, that’s your mess to clean up. But otherwise, this whole fiasco between the four of us never occurred.”

“*What*?” Shinsou hissed. He whirled on his companion, face twisting in anger. “Have you lost your goddamn mind? We’re not keeping this a secret from Aizawa—”

“Yes. We *are*.” Monoma shot a challenging glare.

The two best friends were matched in a grid lock.

Katsuki stared on in wonder because he hadn’t expected it to be fucking *Monoma* that would somehow take his side in this. But there it was, Monoma glaring down Shinsou in a silent promise of violence if he spoke a word about what they knew.

Monsters recognized monsters—but maybe monsters also pitied each other?

Monoma walked up to Shinsou with his shoulders squared out. There, Katsuki could see the years of trust between them shake like a mountain that was supposed to be unmovable. Then quietly, Monoma’s face gave a raw expression Katsuki had also never seen.

“Let him be happy,” Monoma murmured, nearly inaudible.

It was almost a plea—but not quite. It was said to be as close to begging as Monoma could get and was tinted with some disgust. Whatever the tone, Katsuki was grateful as all hell for it. He didn’t even realize his heart was hammering until that second, and he could feel Izuku’s vibrating pulse on him as well.

Gradually, Shinsou gave in. But only barely.

It was easy to tell that Shinsou had his doubts but above all *unease* when he stared at Izuku.

“Fine,” Shinsou agreed without looking at anyone. He pushed his gun back in his holster and folded his arms, fuming. “If this goes wrong—*which it will*—don’t fucking come to us about it, Bakugou. We can keep this a secret between us on one condition: you’re coming back with us tonight to HQ. You’re going to close out immediately.”

“Okay. I’ll come with you,” Katsuki agreed.

“We’ll be waiting on the porch,” Monoma said. He began to push Shinsou by the shoulder towards the door. “Take all the time you need.”

The two left, leaving Izuku and Katsuki alone.

Izuku relaxed, finally uncurling his fist. Katsuki sagged his shoulders and shook his head. He stared down at Izuku’s ankle. Fuck. The injury was clearly throbbing underneath the aggravation of being violently tossed. Izuku was staring at it as well.

“C’mon, let’s get that fixed up before I go,” Katsuki whispered. He lifted Izuku in his arms with regret heavy on his mind. “Sorry he threw you like that.”

Izuku didn’t reply. His eyes were glazed over and turned down and away from him.

This was a bigger mess than Katsuki ever thought it might be.

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki quietly packed a backpack with all the things he needed for an overnight trip. Cellphone. Keys. Extra pair of clothes. His knife and personal handgun. He neatly organized his company’s given suitcase and briefcase with all the borrowed equipment. When he clicked it shut it was odd: all these years, finally coming to an end.

He took off his ring for good measure and placed it on the dresser. Katsuki nearly laughed at the small indent on his skin. Who knew he would keep that thing on for this long?

He glanced up at Izuku across the bed. His accidental husband was sitting neatly on top of the covers, still wearing his birthday sash and fiddling nervously with his own wedding band.

“Will you be okay by yourself?” Katsuki asked as he put on his leather jacket.

“I will,” Izuku said with the saddest smile. He was staring at Katsuki with a type of sorrow that made him worry. He glanced at the emerald ring on the dresser and bit his lip. “I didn’t know I caused you so much trouble. I’m sorry.”

“Don’t worry about it,” Katsuki reassured. He walked around the bed to sit next to Izuku. He placed his hand on top of Izuku’s and squeezed it. “Those assholes will get over it and what my supervisor doesn’t know won’t hurt him. I’ll get the kill order stuff sorted out too.”

Izuku’s face faltered. He pinned up a forced smile in the next moment.

“Okay, Kacchan.”

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki boarded the next train with Monoma and Shinsou. He was unsure about leaving Izuku alone for some reason, but he departed with high hopes that all would be fine.

The three colleagues sat together on the train. Shinsou was trying to meditate his headache away as he texted Aizawa they were on the way back. Katsuki had his arms folded in mild annoyance. Monoma was still attending to his throbbing nose.

“Do you two think you could possibly get Aizawa to lighten up on the kill orders?” Katsuki asked quietly. “If possible, ask him to somehow get rid of them without being suspicious.”

Monoma exhaled roughly through his injured nose.

Shinsou pretended like he didn’t hear him.

“I’ll get something sorted out,” Monoma said tiredly. “I’ll figure out a way to convince Aizawa for you, but I can’t promise it will be instantaneous. So, in the meantime keep an eye on that boyfriend of yours so that he doesn’t get shot while I’m trying to get the order called off.”

“Thank you,” Katsuki said. He nodded gratefully towards the other blond. “That means a lot and sorry about busting your nose. What are you going to tell Aizawa about that by the way?”

“Easy. I’ll tell him you hit me,” Monoma muttered. “I’ll explain how you lost your temper after I said you’re ugly in orange and you slapped me in the face.”

Katsuki frowned. He looked down to his orange turtleneck. “I do not look ugly in orange.”

“And who told you that?”

“I think you know who,” Katsuki grumbled. “As long as he thinks I look nice I don’t need anyone else’s approval.”

“Shut up, Bakugou,” Shinsou rolled his eyes and pressed his forehead further into the window’s glass. “Please. Shut up for the remainder of this train ride. I’m trying very, *very* hard right now not to haul off and shoot you in the dick for thinking with it.”

Monoma cracked an amused smirk. “Does this mean these last few years have been foreplay for the big event?”

Katsuki did a ‘so-so’ motion with his hands. “Very close.”

☽ ☽ ☽

When they arrived back at headquarters it was exactly how Katsuki remembered it to be. It nearly felt like a lifetime ago with how much had happened.

Shinsou and Monoma dragged him inside and directly towards their section of HQ. He was expecting this to be quick and could practically feel Aizawa snatching The Company property right out of his hands and telling him to leave.

However, when they arrived Katsuki was taken off guard. They stopped in front of the biggest conference room on the floor, and it was eerily quiet. Not a soul was in sight, and it was pitch black.

“Are you two setting me up?” Katsuki accused. “Where the fuck is Aizawa?”

Shinsou, clearly down to his last drop of patience, walked into the conference room and flicked on the lights.

“Surprise!” A chorus of voices yelled at maximum volume.

The jump scare nearly made Katsuki have a heart attack. He stumbled back and his eyes took forever to adjust to the blinding fucking lights that flooded everywhere. He blinked rapidly,

attempting to shade his vision with his hands.

When his eyes finally refocused he saw everyone who he worked with closely standing around. They had big, goofy grins painted on their faces. The entire room was overly decorated with red, yellow and blue streamers and balloons. On the white board was *"Goodbye and Good luck, Bakugou!"* in Denki's sloppy penmanship. Next to that was a long table with various types of foods and drinks stationed around.

M-Unit was front and center with Aizawa and Miruko, jumping up and down. In the back were a couple other people he passed the time with smiling and waving at him.

Katsuki scratched at the back of his head, slightly flustered. He walked in slowly with Monoma by his side, who was giving his signature shit eating smirk.

"Surprise, you bastard," Monoma laughed. He knocked him in the shoulder and went straight for the alcohol. Monoma pointed his finger at Aizawa accompanied with a sharp glare. "You owe me six weeks' vacation for dragging this lunatic all the way back here."

Confetti was then tossed on Katsuki by Miruko and Denki who were shouting eagerly.

Aizawa, with a stale face, blew into a party blower that made an obnoxiously loud sound. "Hurray. You're done."

Katsuki was dumbfounded. "You all threw me a surprise party?"

"Yes." Sero laughed as he joined in throwing more confetti with Denki and Miruko. "One that we have been planning for you for almost four months now! I didn't think it would take sending scary serial killers one and two over here to drag your ass back to us. But I'm glad it worked."

"Are you wearing *orange*?" Miruko gasped.

Katsuki's face grew hot when everyone gasped. He cleared his throat and smoothed out his turtleneck. "Yes. I'm…I'm trying out new colors. Does it look nice?"

"You look like a grumpy tangerine," Denki chuckled.

Katsuki blushed and scowled. "Fuck off, Pikachu."

"Missed you too, cranky," Denki teased.

Everyone gestured for him to get food and slowly the night blended away.

☽ ☽ ☽

Throughout the whole party Katsuki talked to people he knew and some he didn't. He had never suspected he had impacted this many individuals for them to show up for him, but there they were.

Aizawa and him officially closed out. His supervisor brought all the paperwork to the party with a fresh, crisp scarlet pen. Everyone watched and cheered as Katsuki signed the last of his contract. It wasn't really much to consent on. Simply stating he understood that if he ever spoke a word about what occurred in the last decade, he would be granted death.

Katsuki grinned, feeling very lucky at that moment. He signed his name happily on the dotted line.

Riotous roars and party favors were jeered, creating the loudest sound to declare he was done. Katsuki grinned until his face felt numb and he sipped on his drink more.

All the commotion died down, and people began to talk amongst themselves.

Katsuki watched silently as he observed the life he officially was done with. Miruko was chatting it up with Denki and a couple people from her own unit. Shinsou was stationed off to the side, effectively becoming a wallflower but giving him a quiet, unimpressed stare. Monoma was chatting with his girlfriend who was tempting Sero to come join her in karaoke after hours.

And Aizawa was standing off to the side, swirling his glass of liquor. His now ex-supervisor was dressed in his crisp black and white suit with no tie. He came off as tired, with shoulders heavier than gravity. He pushed back a single gray strand of hair, and somehow he seemed older than he was.

Katsuki glanced over his shoulder before walking over towards Aizawa.

"Hey, can I talk to you about something?" Katsuki whispered once he was close enough.

Aizawa lifted his tired eyes to him. "Sure, what is it?"

"Hypothetically, let's say someone who is in our profession needs to disappear permanently."

He probably should've worded that better because *immediately* Aizawa was disgruntled. His ex-boss sighed heavily, stood up straight, and downed the whole of his drink in one swig.

"Let me start over," Katsuki said quickly before Aizawa could interject. "I know that hitmen need to go underground after shit hits the fan sometimes. Once, I saw you help a woman, and you gave her some type of black folder with instructions. I want to know how to get a hold of this information."

"Are you trying to disappear?" Aizawa whispered wearily. He glanced around and pulled Katsuki further into the corner. "Is this about Chizome? Did something happen?"

"No, this is definitely not about that *bastard*," Katsuki snapped, irritated. His unbridled anger boiled a bit, and nearly escaped him. He willed his rage back down and tried to refocus. "This is something different. If someone who has a very bloody, complicated past needed to get away without a trace, how would that happen?"

"They would need to locate someone who is very good at doing that."

“And who is that someone?”

“My old black folders have all the information,” Aizawa said quietly. He tilted his head and glared at Katsuki. “Enough with the weird code speak. Is this pertaining to the Okinawa assignment because I *thought* that ended strangely. Do you need assistance in something? Because I won’t mind helping if this is the last thing to get you done.”

“It’s not for me,” Katsuki hurried out. “It’s for—a friend. Someone who isn’t here.”

Aizawa’s face grew stale. “You don’t have any other friends besides the questionable morons in this room.”

Katsuki bristled at how that wasn’t exactly false. “Could you get the information? *Please*?”

“I can get it for you,” Aizawa said suspiciously. “I will admit, it has been a while since anyone from The Company needed to disappear and the information I have might be outdated. But it can give you a good starting point and I think you can figure out where to go after tracking some patterns. I’ll need to go back to my office and grab a few things. Finding a copy of those black folders might take a while, so don’t wait up. If you need to leave for the train I will have it delivered to your address.”

Katsuki nodded happily. This was good.

This was Izuku’s out.

“What are you two doing over here whispering in the corner?” Miruko poked at them. She walked up to both of them with a beaming grin and shoulder bumped Aizawa. “I can see the rain clouds over both of your heads, come back out to society and lighten up.”

Katsuki laughed and Aizawa dryly chuckled.

They returned to the party, and everyone began taking Company photos and telling stories of Katsuki’s time there. In the midst of everyone’s celebration, Katsuki turned to look at Aizawa. He caught his ex-supervisor staring at the message on the white board.

There was a sadness in his eyes as he read the word 'Goodbye’.

☽ ☽ ☽

After the going away party, Katsuki felt extremely light. He also felt sorrowful in an unjustified manner.

It was surreal. No more Sero pining for Denki. No more Shinsou and Monoma being the creepy duo together. No more Aizawa getting irritated at them. No more watching people get scolded by Aizawa and Miruko. No more everyone blending together as one.

He was actually finished with his side of his life.

Katsuki kicked a balloon as he walked around the empty conference room. He took out his favorite blade and it felt lighter and looked different in the lighting of his new life. Katsuki

turned over the handle to stare at where he had etched his mother's name.

A dullness raked through him at the sight of the letters.

"You're still here?" Aizawa's voice suddenly came through. "It's almost midnight. You'll miss the last train out."

Katsuki glanced towards the door, surprised to find his ex-supervisor there. The elder man was leaning against the doorframe with a black envelope in his hands. He stared at the party streamers that were still perched on the wall and the discarded confetti laying scattered on the floor.

"Hah. Yeah." Katsuki shrugged off. "I, uh, am taking my time to leave, that's all."

Aizawa nodded in silence. He walked into the room and stared around too like he was going to miss it.

"Is everything okay?" Aizawa asked when Katsuki still hadn't moved an inch.

"I'm fine, old man," Katsuki grumbled. He leaned against the table and turned over the blade in his hand. "Relax and have another glass of wine before you start to annoy me."

"I worry over you, is that a crime?" Aizawa grumbled back. He walked over to where Katsuki was and leaned against the table next to him. "I think it's officially a habit."

"Why do you worry so much about me?" Katsuki asked.

"Maybe it has something to do with discovering one of my best men was killed by a thirteen-year-old boy," Aizawa said sarcastically, shooting him an unimpressed stare. "Then finding out that same boy was a hair away from passing out from starvation but was *wild* with the will to survive."

Katsuki dryly chuckled. "Well, I'm not that boy anymore. So why do you keep worrying?"

"I guess, what I'm saying is, you have extremely volatile emotions, Bakugou," Aizawa explained in a concerned murmur. "I've always recognized that. Especially whenever it pertained to your mother, you become a loose cannon within a split second. But I also understand why you're like that because I used to be like that too."

"And how am I like?" Katsuki questioned, bored. He knew this was about to be another lecture as he fiddled with his knife.

"You were never given space to process emotions that take time: grief, sadness, and anger," Aizawa pointed out, catching Katsuki's attention. "You always had to keep it moving and bottle every emotion in because there wasn't time to grieve, or cry, or be reasonably upset. But as a result, eventually those emotions build up and—" Aizawa gestured wide with his hands. "—Explode."

It was a doomsday warning.

The mood shifted and Katsuki paused enough to lower his blade.

“You think I’m going to explode one day?” Katsuki wearily whispered.

“You already have exploded once,” Aizawa muttered with a shrug. “You unleashed all your pent-up emotions onto Muscular and that was *before* Mitsuki died. I don’t want you to do that again, even more so on someone you may not want to. You had a target last time, Muscular was easily pinned for your issues in life, but next time it may not be like that. I know you have unprocessed grief pertaining to Mitsuki—so. I worry.”

Katsuki internally surveyed himself for a second.

He had never considered that his emotions were that dangerous.

“If I can give you one last lecture, the moral is to take time for your emotions,” Aizawa suggested. “Since you’ll be retired, remember it’s okay to feel at that moment. You don’t have to bottle it in anymore.”

“Thanks, old man,” Katsuki whispered. “I’ll remember that.”

“Oh, by the way.” Aizawa handed over the black folder. “Here’s the information you asked for. The connection hasn’t been heard from in several years because she moves around a lot. She also has a lot of various aliases but it’s for the better. Since the law isn’t particularly kind to murderers like us, a lot of underground strings must be pulled. But I’m sure, you’ll be able to easily trace where to go with your tracking skills.”

Katsuki stared at the envelope like it was a daydream.

This was the key to getting Izuku out and potentially the kids he mentioned as well. He swallowed. The direness of the whole situation was quickly coming to light.

“And this is a sure-fire thing?” Katsuki asked. “It won’t backfire at all?”

“It’s extremely bulletproof.” Aizawa hummed. “It might take some digging to find the starting point since my information is years old, but that’s simply how this whole thing works. So, if you’re going to disappear, then take care, Bakugou. It was really nice getting to know you and I’m glad you’re finally going to find some peace.”

Aizawa wore his emotional mask well. That was something Katsuki always admired about the elder man. Stiff. Straight face and always damn professional. But right now, that mask slipped a little to reveal a subtle sadness.

Aizawa and him exchange one last set of goodbyes, a dry handshake and then the elder man headed towards the door with a heaviness on his shoulders. Right before he could leave, Katsuki blurted out something he wanted to say for so long, but his pride always prevented him from doing so.

“I’m sorry, for what I said at my mother’s funeral,” Katsuki said.

Aizawa stopped cold in his tracks.

The elder man turned around like he misheard, and his emotionless mask was wiped clean off.

Katsuki shifted uncomfortably, still unfamiliar with this level of vulnerability.

“Um.” Katsuki rubbed at his nape. “You’re right, I get—*angry*—about anything pertaining to her and I react poorly. I lashed out on you that day and I didn’t mean what I said. I never properly apologized for that. So. I’m sorry.”

“You weren’t wrong.” Aizawa put his hands in his pants’ pockets. “I’m not your parent and I shouldn’t have acted like I was when I have made poor choices pertaining to you too. I’m not exactly a golden role model for hiring a teenager at this operation. I should have turned you away when you asked for a job more vigorously, but I didn’t.”

“But you’re the closest thing to a parent I have,” Katsuki finally admitted out loud. “Thank you, for watching over me all these years when no one else did.”

Katsuki walked up to Aizawa and hesitantly embraced him in a hug.

They knocked together awkwardly, and it was stiff. From the outside view it would be cringe to see, Katsuki assumed. The sudden onset of unnamed emotions made Katsuki realize, Aizawa was right. He did have shit bottled up so tightly that he was liable to explode at the smallest thing if he wasn’t careful.

When they separated Aizawa was giving him a fond look of pride.

“Keep in touch if you can, kid,” Aizawa whispered with tears in his throat.

Katsuki did a two-finger salute and smirked. “You know I will.”

When Aizawa was gone, Katsuki decided to open up the folder.

Inside was a map, a set of old addresses, and a photograph of a woman with sleek black hair. Her eyes were pretty, round, and a deep shade of brown that was warm like cinnamon. Attached to the information was the name Shimura Nana.

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki missed the last train out, just like Aizawa had warned he would. He couldn’t stop himself from lingering around the building and eventually shacked up in a small motel for the night.

He realized then he didn’t have Izuku’s number to tell him he was alright. He also realized then he didn’t actually know much about Izuku’s background or life besides what was unwillingly revealed. But with that black folder brought new hopes and soon Izuku’s past wouldn’t even matter.

He could perfectly envision it:

First he would tell Izuku about Shimura Nana and how bulletproof this type of disappearance program was. The beautiful man would be shocked, afraid, but willing. They would escape to go find her hand in hand. Izuku would finally be cut free from the grasp of whatever fucking ugly web he was trapped in. Katsuki didn't care if it meant they had to relocate to a new country or a remote part of Japan.

He would even pre-sell the estate if that's what it entailed. It would be perfect because they could use the money to build a new somewhere else.

Anything would be good to pay for the price of Izuku's freedom being returned.

When he arrived back at the estate, Katsuki was gripping the black folder with clammy palms.

He was excited as he unlocked the door, but when he walked inside, he was met with a quiet house.

"Izuku?" Katsuki called.

No answer.

He wearily saw Izuku's crutches laying off to the side by the TV. He searched around, and he found all of Izuku's books, his clothes, and his suitcase. As he wandered around calling Izuku's name, he passed by the back area of the estate and heard faint crying.

Katsuki glanced through a window to the large chunk of land in the back. The field was lush today, overflowing with red, higanbana flowers bending with the breeze. He could faintly see a pop of green—Izuku. He was sitting in the field crying. His head was down as his shoulders shook vehemently.

Katsuki ran out into the field immediately in fear that Izuku was hurt.

"Izuku!" Katsuki called his name when he came into ear shot.

Izuku violently flinched and snapped his head up.

His eyes were bloodshot, tiny red vessels nearly overflowing the whites of his eyes. All the delicate skin around his face was puffy as if he had been crying for hours on end. He was dressed in his olive colored samue and it was wrinkled like there had been a tussle. Izuku scrambled to wipe his tears.

Katsuki immediately kneeled down and inspected Izuku all over. "What happened? Why are you out here crying?"

Izuku sniffled, still wiping his eyes. He stared at Katsuki as if he had seen a ghost, or worse, a demon. There was potent fear in his eyes that Katsuki had never witnessed in all his years of knowing him. This was new. Izuku stared down at Katsuki's bare wedding finger.

"You would never hurt me…would you?" Izuku asked, barely above a whisper.

Katsuki was taken back. His whole body halted movement and he searched Izuku's face. All he could see was a thick cloud of anxiety.

"Of course, I wouldn't," Katsuki said. He took a closer look at Izuku's ankle, but his hand was stopped. The smaller hand gripped him tightly—nearly desperate. "Where is this coming from?"

"I'm—I'm only wondering," Izuku's voice wavered. "The time we spent here meant something for you?"

"It means everything."

"A-And no matter what, you wouldn't—no, couldn't—kill me?" Izuku sobbed.

Katsuki was rendered speechless.

Did Izuku really have doubts about that, even after the last few months? Immediately, Katsuki blamed his two fucking frightening ass ex-coworkers, Shinsou and Monoma. Maybe he should've been more forceful with them when they were calling Izuku names and mentioning all the past things he had said about him.

Katsuki interlaced their fingers and his heart clutched at how hard Izuku was trembling.

"I would never try to kill you," Katsuki promised.

Izuku didn't seem convinced. "B-But what about the kill orders you have on me?"

Ah. There it is.

"Those were only because you butchered Rin Hiyru and kept messing with assignments. That shouldn't be surprising. All that is in the past now, I told you I would get the kill order shit straightened up. My ex-colleague is working on clearing it soon when he can."

"How long did you have the orders?" Izuku continued, ignoring pretty much all he said.

Katsuki pursed his lips to the side, trying to have patience. "I was ordered to kill you the second I saw you after Madrid."

"But you never did."

"Because I wasn't trying to blow my goddamn cover with Moore looking at us as hard as he was."

"So would you have killed me if Moore didn't get involved?"

Katsuki opened his mouth, then he closed it. He caressed Izuku's shoulders lightly. "Izuku, where is this coming from? You're worrying me. You never answered why you were out here crying in the first place."

"Please, answer the question," Izuku said, voice splintering entirely.

Katsuki took a deep breath. The next words made him feel sticky with regret. “Yes. If we hadn’t run into Moore, I would have attempted to kill you. But that’s irrelevant because I had been trying to kill you for years. That shouldn’t be surprising or a testament to anything.”

Izuku nodded in understanding, but not happily. His hand recoiled to himself, and his crying eased up.

Katsuki ‘tsk’d under his breath and shuffled in closely to Izuku to hold him with one arm.

“C’mon, Izuku. This is stupid. That’s the past and we’ve always been at odds until recently. But everything is different now and that’s good. So, what if we had crossed some issues in our line of work? I had no clue who you were before.”

“I could never kill you, even when I didn’t know,” Izuku said, barely audible. “I-I th-thought it might be the same.”

Katsuki rubbed Izuku’s shoulders and hugged him. Damn. He felt guilty. Izuku was shaken up more by that stupid intrusion more than he thought. He probably was triggered, and Katsuki fucking *left* him here alone to spiral in his thoughts.

“I’m sorry,” Katsuki whispered and kissed Izuku’s forehead. “I’m really sorry that I can’t say I felt the same when you were only Deku to me—but I can say that *now* and that’s all that matters. You’re the only person I’ve ever felt this…*close* to. Shit happens, feelings change. I would never try to kill you again if that’s what you’re worried about. Nothing could change that.”

“Nothing?”

“Nothing.”

Izuku hugged him back.

Katsuki was confused as all hell, but he did his best to calm Izuku down. He ran a hand through Izuku’s messy curls and held him tightly. When he did this, something caught his eye. He noticed stray leaves and lone higanbana flower petals stuck in Izuku’s thick curls. Even dirt was caked in his hair at to the roots.

Katsuki frowned unhappily and began plucking Izuku’s hair clean.

“Now that your irrational fears are settled, why were you out here in the middle of the field crying?” Katsuki asked once more. “A little fucking concerning, don’t you think?”

“It’s nothing to worry about,” Izuku explained. “I tried seeing if I could walk on my own. Looks like I can’t yet.”

Izuku pulled back and smiled at him a little, but not all the way.

Something was tethering him and keeping him from being entirely happy.

Katsuki recognized it as fear.

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki couldn't shake that conversation out of his head.

It was unsettling and it reeked of Izuku being rattled by an unknown deterrent.

Katsuki worried that the run-in with Monoma and Shinsou impacted Izuku far more than he assumed. He drew this conclusion because over the next two days, Izuku was quieter than usual and mildly withdrawn. He was looking out of the windows, smiling sparingly and only sometimes joked around.

It felt like Izuku was pulling further away on purpose.

Which brought him to now, currently in the kitchen. Katsuki had placed his wedding band back on his finger and he was at the stove making chicken curry in a pot. Izuku was sitting at the table staring down at his lap in deep thought. His book was untouched, which worried Katsuki. Usually, Izuku read while he cooked.

The static radio was playing in the background. Originally it was nothing worthwhile, then a subject piqued his attention.

"We are interviewing a survivor from the Okinawa human trafficking tragedy. She is speaking out," the voice of a news reporter announced. Both Izuku and Katsuki sharply cut their eyes towards the tiny device. "Now tell us, what did you see again? This seems to conflict with the original police reports."

"There was a man in all black with blood-colored eyes," the wobbly voice of the witness whispered. "His eyes nearly glowed in the dark—and he moved so fluidly through all the rooms. He saved us from those monsters, like an angel of death reaping all of their souls."

Katsuki pressed his lips in a thin line. *Did they seriously call me an angel of death?*

"Do you think this could potentially be the work of the mysterious Scarlet Eyed Killer?" The reporter probed. "The description of his eyes combined with the amount of blood shed matches—"

Katsuki quickly turned the radio off.

"Sorry," Katsuki grumbled and went back to cooking. "I don't exactly feel like reliving that. I still get fucking hives thinking about the cages and red rooms. Plus, I don't really want to hear if I have another goddamn nickname. First The Scarlet Eyed Killer, now The Angel of Death? It's too much."

He didn't get a response.

Katsuki peeked over his shoulder.

Instead of answering him, Izuku was staring down at his hand, tracing a particular scar.

When Katsuki inspected closer, he recognized it as a scar that he inflicted from one of their many scuffles over the years. He had taken his blade edged with his mother's name and slashed it at Izuku. The other man barely had time to dodge, and in defense put his hand up—and the edge of the blade cut right through his palm.

Back then, Katsuki was happy to see pain inflicted on Izuku. But watching Izuku study that scar after their conversation in the garden made him feel uneasy. The look in his eyes was distant, and his lips were pressed in a contemplative line.

"Katsuki," Izuku whispered without glancing up. "We should get the divorce this week."

Katsuki's heart stopped. Then he continued stirring the curry in the pot and gritted his teeth.

Several beats of silence passed.

Izuku frowned and finally lifted his gaze. "Katsuki. Did you hear me?"

"I heard you."

"…And?"

Katsuki sucked in a deep breath. He clicked off the stove and turned around with a determined stare.

"And I don't want a divorce."

Izuku looked at him sideways. "Wh-What? We can't stay married—"

"Why not? We like each other. *A lot.* We get along fucking splendidly or whatever the hell it's called. Why would we get divorced?"

Izuku stared at him unimpressed now and folded his arms. "So, what's your plan? We secretly date in between my assignments and build up to justifying being legally married?"

"My plan is you don't have any more assignments," Katsuki answered.

This time, Izuku really did stare at him like he had gone mad. However, there was longing in his eyes too. Katsuki was compelled by the emotions dripping from Izuku and walked over to him. He pulled out the chair and sat down to eye level with the other man.

"Izuku. I want you to stay here with me."

Familiarity settled inside of him.

When he grasped Izuku's hands, it felt the same as when they were kids in that cramped nook. He had begged Izuku to marry him in hopes of the other boy being with him forever. And now, Katsuki was pleading for the same thing years later. He was scared for Izuku's safety all over again along with his own fear of being alone gnawing at him.

Izuku had said yes back then, and he could say it again.

However, the spark of childhood was nowhere to be found in Izuku's eyes. Instead, the ropes of reality were anchoring him to his next words: "I have to leave, Katsuki. I can't stay with you."

A piece of him shattered.

"But you shouldn't go back to that place," Katsuki tried to reason. His grip on Izuku's hands grew tighter, the same way they had that day in the nook. "Don't you like it here with me?"

"Of course I like it here but you're not making sense."

"No. *You're* not making sense," Katsuki snapped. Patience had never been his strong suit and his emotions were biting and churning in their cage. "You have an *out*, Izuku. Why go back to a place where you're fucking abused? You could stay here, and we could figure out a way to keep you away from people who would track you down. Look. I asked my supervisor about disappearance help—"

"—I don't get to disappear, Katsuki," Izuku cut off, annoyed. He pulled his hands out of Katsuki's and shook his head. "My life isn't simple like that and going through some disappearance program won't work for me."

"Well, we can make it fucking work. How do you know if you don't try? Hah? At least give it a shot."

"No. Katsuki, stop. That isn't realistic—"

"—*Realistic*?" Katsuki huffed, frustrated. He leaned away from Izuku in disbelief. "Staying somewhere where you're *free* versus a place you were fucking *sold* to isn't *realistic*?"

Izuku glared at him and gritted his teeth. "No. It's not."

"Y'know what—if we're going to rip the reality Band-Aid off, *let's*."

Katsuki leaned menacingly into Izuku's face, and they locked in unmoving glares. He curled his upper lip as he spat his next words.

"I'm not allowing you to go back to somewhere that forces you to kill." Katsuki glowered. "I will triple deadbolt all these doors and break your limbs before I allow you to go back to somewhere like that, Izuku. And I fucking *mean it*. Especially when you should have been with *me*. You should've—"

His anger dissipated an inch when he could envision young Izuku with a bandaged eye, smiling at him in the winter.

"You should've been with me all this time." Katsuki's eyes and voice softened. "Me leaving Tokyo was a mistake and we can correct it now. Why else would we have come across each other again all these years? It's—"

Fate.

Katsuki swallowed that word again.

Izuku's eyes lowered and the anger inside of them went with them. Now Izuku was only distant and sullen as he spoke next.

"But you *did* leave Tokyo, and I *didn't*. That's reality," Izuku whispered. He looked down at his hands and traced that scar on his palm again. "We can't correct how we branched into different paths. No matter how much I wish we could, we can't and I'm pushing my *limit*, Katsuki. My time is basically up. I borrowed all the favors I could to stay here for as long as I can, but I *can't* stay any longer and we can't stay married."

Izuku's voice was pained beyond his years.

Katsuki shook his head in denial.

This wasn't how he imagined this conversation going. Izuku was supposed to say yes. Izuku was supposed to get set free and they could be together finally. Izuku was supposed to stay. He was supposed to stay. He was supposed to—

"Who the fuck do I have to kill if you need to get out?" Katsuki begged viciously. "That big brother? Your supervisor? The fucking *Governor*? I don't give a damn how many throats I have to slit if it means you don't go back to the place that you were trafficked to. Do you hear how insane that sounds?! You want to stay here, don't you?"

Izuku flinched at something and turned his head away from Katsuki. "Nothing in my life is about what I want."

"But if it was—you would want to stay here with me, wouldn't you?"

"Of course, I would."

"Exactly. You like it here. You want this type of life as badly as I do, and we fit together so fucking well."

Katsuki gently took Izuku's chin and turned his face so they could see each other. Izuku's wall was crumbling, and his emotions were beginning to be laid bare. Katsuki's heart squeezed and squeezed until vulnerable words spilled out.

"You're more than a passing moment in my life and you know I'm more than that to you," Katsuki whispered and gently stroked Izuku's chin with his thumb. "These last few months were proof of how our lives should be—we should be *together*; we always should've been, and I don't want to let you go."

Love birds aren't meant to be separated, Katsuki could hear the warning of the old violinist. *They always come back to each other and find one another.*

He cusped Izuku's face with both hands and held eye contact. He searched in the eyes he loved so much for any hint that Izuku agreed. And he found an abundance of it. Izuku's words didn't match his eyes and Katsuki could see how much Izuku was fighting against his own will.

“Please, Izuku. Stay with me this time.”

Izuku’s beautiful face crumbled. He sobbed and lifted his trembling hands up to Katsuki’s. He grasped Katsuki’s wrists and slowly lowered their hands down onto his lap.

“I can’t stay because there are kids.”

Time stopped.

“…What?” Katsuki whispered.

But he knew the answer when he considered a grim fact he never thought of before. He stared at the number 217 on Izuku’s skin like it was a mark of death. It made him sick to his stomach as his perspective was widened.

“A-At my home, in Tokyo—there’re *kids*.” Izuku tried to stop his tears and clenched his jaw. “I can’t leave them there alone, Katsuki. I *can’t*. I have one I’m supposed to watch over. I’m his big brother like my big brother is to me. His name is Katsuma and he’s so soft. I can’t leave him there to be broken and hurt. Or worse, killed.”

“Have you been trying to get them out?” Katsuki asked, suddenly very sober on reality.

“Of course I have,” Izuku muttered. “I could never forgive myself if I let them do what they did to me to them. I can’t fix what occurred, but I can prevent it from happening again.”

“Then let me help,” Katsuki easily offered. He sat up like it was a sure-fire idea. “I have the information of someone named Nana who might be able to get us a lead on what to do. I can go back with you to Tokyo, and we can do it together and then we can—”

“No!” Izuku snapped angrily and tore himself away from Katsuki. “Just fucking stop!”

Katsuki slammed his fist on the table. “Are you serious?! Why are you so damn insistent on us being separated again?!”

“Because you’re *out*!” Izuku’s voice boomed on all the walls.

Katsuki was stunned speechless at the sheer volume that erupted from Izuku.

“You’re *finally* out, why would I drag you back in with my own mess?!” Izuku continued, heated glare in full intensity. “Don’t you get it? This is why I have been trying to help you get set up. You’re done! You’re *free*! You can start all the way over! You deserve to be normal—at least that way one of us can be!”

Izuku’s chest heaved as he caught his breath. His lips pulled back as he curled his fists like something was eating him from the inside out.

“I’ll *never* be normal,” Izuku admitted gravely. “There is no contract or number of years for me to be released. This is who I am and between the two of us, only one of us is a real sinner and it’s not you. I have done t-terrible things, Katsuki. Shit I can’t undo no matter how much

I wish I could and because of that, I cannot stay here. I want to do right for you, Katsuki and I'm not right for you."

"You can't decide what's right for me—"

"—Believe me on this one," Izuku whispered. "We're not meant to be together."

Katsuki would never say out loud how much that hurt him.

He curled his fists and his frown hardened to stop the tears that pushed at his eyes. He never cried easily—but hearing that forced him to keep in the tears for once in his life. The kettle on the stove top went off, reminding him that he had food going. It whistled shrilly in their uncomfortable silence.

When Izuku's hard expression wavered ever so slightly, Katsuki decided he didn't believe a fucking word the man was saying. Izuku was doing this on purpose to push him away because that's who Izuku was: annoyingly selfless. He would be the goddamn type to lie in hopes of making shit easier. Katsuki wasn't about to give into that crap a single bit.

"You don't mean that," Katsuki hissed defensively. "And you're *not* fucking going back alone if I can help it. If you leave out of here without me, I am going to be right behind you whether you like it or not." He stood up angrily and went back over to the stove to prepare two plates. "This conversation is done and we're not getting a divorce."

Izuku didn't utter another word as he wiped his tears away.

Katsuki walked back over to the dining table and unceremoniously shoved Izuku his plate of curry and took his seat again.

They ate in silence and barely looked at each other.

☽ ☽ ☽

After their fight, they didn't bring up the topic of the divorce or leaving again.

Izuku was wearing a weary face that only pissed Katsuki off and all their problems stayed suspended in the air. Izuku didn't want to go—that much Katsuki could see but the stubborn asshole was acting as though he *had* to go. Which hurt Katsuki even more.

He tried his best to push down those whispers in the back of his mind, but it was hard. They came back again, full force.

"The problem is you," his self-doubt murmured. "You're not a good enough person for him to stay."

"Even if he does like you, he's going to leave you," his anxiety muttered. "One day you'll wake up and be by yourself again."

"You're unlovable," his self-hatred stated cruelly. "How could he ever love a monster like you? You chose to be a killer. Izuku didn't."

These whispers grew louder and louder every single passing moment.

It wasn't before long Katsuki's desperation grew. He could see Izuku begin to distance himself, but he knew he had a small chance at making Izuku stay. It was apparent in Izuku's eyes.

When Izuku didn't think he was looking, green eyes stared longingly at anything in sight. The kitchen. The couch. The fall leaves on the trees. But most of all, Izuku stared longingly at him sometimes. Then Katsuki heard a whisper that would solidify his resolve.

Izuku had locked himself in the bathroom in the middle of the night once. His accidental husband had been tossing and turning, unable to relax. He had climbed out of the bed, assuming Katsuki was asleep. But he wasn't. He was awake and he crept up slowly and pressed his ear against the shut door.

"Wh-Why did it have to be this way?" Izuku sobbed angrily. His voice was so quiet and muffled. His crying was heartbreaking and frustrating. "I don't understand. I don't want it to be like th-this."

Katsuki didn't want it to be like this either.

Which is why he knew if he kept pushing it—then maybe he could convince Izuku to stay willingly. Then they could have a chance at the happiness they both deserved.

There was only one thing left to do in Katsuki's mind.

It terrified him—but he knew there was a chance for them if he laid himself bare for Izuku to see.

☽ ☽ ☽

"Where are we going?" Izuku asked.

He was using his crutches again, a minor setback after the encounter with Monoma. He stared curiously at Katsuki who was tying his boot up into a neat bow.

"You'll see when we get there," Katsuki explained. He mumbled a little under his breath because his heart was pounding furiously. He smiled at Izuku who was patiently waiting for him. "Are you ready to get going?"

Izuku nodded and began to hop on his crutches towards the door. Katsuki stopped him, and gently placed the crutches on the ground. He squatted low for Izuku to ride on his back. There was hesitation but Izuku climbed on. Katsuki swallowed his nerves when they spiked because he hoped this would be able to help Izuku understand how he felt.

They walked through the field together, admiring the distant landscapes. It was still dark outside and before sunrise. Everything was silent in the gentle darkness as they traveled through the field of higanbanas in the back of the estate. They walked towards the density of the trees that were awaiting them.

Izuku was quiet and Katsuki was too. The howling wind blew through their hair when they breached the threshold for the dense forest. Their figures were shaded by vibrant orange and red trees.

Katsuki took a path that he sometimes wished to forget existed. He had stricken it from his memory, like so many things he did when they pained him too much. Similar to the same fate Izuku fell to as the blurry faced boy in his dreams.

Izuku's attention was caught when they found a stone pathway in the forest. They followed it all the way to a bridge that passed over a tiny stream. The echoing of the morning birds and running water were the only sound as they trekked deeper in the scarlet forestry.

"What is this place?" Izuku asked.

"It's…better to show you."

The pathway turned to an unkept, white marble path that looked as if it hadn't been tended to in years. The crunch of Katsuki's feet on the leaves under his boot pierced the silence.

When they arrived at the clearing, it was exactly the same as Katsuki remembered it. Haunting. Beautiful. Full of death. The only place here at the estate that might truly be filled with ghosts.

Several rows and rows of tombstones were neatly aligned with green moss overrunning them. Higanbana flowers naturally grew, making the dirt floor of the forest seem like it was painted red. In the back were the older tombs, reaching towards the sky as if they were alive and pointing to the deities in the questionable heavens. Those had the most moss covering them, swallowing whoever's name was written.

Then gradually as the rows pushed further and further to the front, newer tombs could be easily distinguished. They were a deep gray. Spots of stone peaked from underneath the thick green and on the tombs were names that faded away from the harshness of nature through the years.

In the utmost front row were three tombs. The newest ones.

Katsuki took a deep breath to steady himself. The wind cut through him again, and he glanced above to stare at the strangely enchanting sight of the thick vines hanging down from the treetops. The vines spread all around like veins, reaching and connecting every tomb limb to limb through their blood.

His blood.

Katsuki walked up to one and grew quiet.

The subtle etching of the name 'Mitsuki' was faintly visible.

Izuku's eyes went wide. "This—This is…" The words trailed off, but he didn't need to finish.

“Yes. It. I…I moved her here when I found this place,” Katsuki admitted. “It felt right to reunite them after they had spent a lifetime apart. Maybe they are finally making amends on the other side, or at least that’s what I tell myself to feel better. Who knows if this was the right thing to do?”

Izuku’s arms that were wrapped around him grew tight.

Carefully, Katsuki let Izuku down. They both sat on the thick forest floor as the red leaves swayed above them. Katsuki worried that this was possibly a weird thing to do when Izuku didn’t speak—then he turned to Katsuki and smiled sadly.

“You did the right thing,” Izuku said quietly. “You have a good heart, Kacchan.”

“I hope I do,” Katsuki muttered, unsure. “This is the only place I didn’t have the real strength to come back to, more than the nursery. I feel guilty sometimes, living in that house and not paying my respects to the people who left it here for me.”

He turned his eyes to the other two tombstones. The names ‘Ren’ and ‘Hina’ were fainter than ‘Mitsuki’.

“Do you ever wonder what they were like?” Izuku asked.

“All the time.” Katsuki smiled a little. “I try to pick out which parts of my mother’s personality belonged to who and it—it makes her feel complete.”

“…What was she like?”

“She was a hurricane,” Katsuki grumbled fondly. “Funny. Risk taker. Energetic. Secretive. Loud. Irresponsible. Caring in her own way.”

“She sounds like she was nice.” Izuku whispered. “I can tell you loved her a lot.”

“I did, but I also resented her too,” Katsuki admitted. “You know that type of resentment you feel guilty for, but it sits inside of you anyways. I used to ignore it all the time because I never want to hate her but…I think I’m finally accepting that two truths can exist at once. I loved her fiercely. But I resented her quietly.”

The wind blew between them, shaking the leaves and swaying the vines above their heads.

“I…I brought you here because this is the last part of me, Izuku.”

Katsuki turned inwards towards him and there was a subtle sadness pooling out of Izuku. Maybe it was a pity. Or maybe the words they tossed around the other day still stung like wasps. Whichever it was, Katsuki took Izuku’s hand in his and gripped it tightly as he continued speaking.

“There’s nothing more I think I can show you or tell you. You have all of me and this is the most vulnerable I’ve ever been with anyone. I know you don’t like to talk about yourself a lot—and I can respect that because it is easy to see, certain things hurt you to think about. But I want you to see all of me because I trust you—entirely.”

Izuku smiled as if Katsuki's words were made of glass. He fixed his posture and then leaned in. Izuku embraced him and buried his face into his neck.

"Thank you for trusting me enough to bring me here," Izuku whispered. "I trust you too."

☽ ☽ ☽

The Bakugous who wandered here before them had made the family grave site something beautiful, Katsuki thought. Despite the morbidness, the scene was deathly beautiful like phantoms who had siren-like voices.

A small lake was found the further into the grave site they went, and there was an all-white gazebo poised like a lone soldier who had survived years of grief by itself. It was overrun with vines and dusted with red leaves. It was perfectly stationed next to the lake, giving a sanctuary to rest.

Katsuki wandered near it, and they sat inside. Wordlessly, the two of them watched the sunrise together. It wasn't the first sunrise they witnessed with the other, but this one was different. The rosy dusk bled up from the ground and into the water. It spread all over like harmless fire, covering everything in its warmth.

Both of them stared quietly.

Izuku's eyes were distant as he stared at their reflections in the water. He stared and stared as if they would shape shift into two people who might have a shot of being together.

"I thought…I thought that this would be easier, somehow," Izuku broke the silence. He didn't turn to Katsuki, only stared at him through their reflections in the lake. "I thought I could come here, spend all the time I could with you, then we could go our separate ways easily. I thought, maybe, seeing you set up and happy here, would make it easier for me to leave. Because I knew this time, you were safe. But leaving you never will be easy. Will it?"

Katsuki's heart clutched. He turned towards the other man whose expression was steadily growing detached. "Izuku. We could find a way to get the kids out and run away. Just don't go back."

"Maybe I shouldn't." Izuku shrugged distantly. "Wouldn't that be crazy if I actually decided to do something…for myself. For once."

"It wouldn't be crazy, it would be good," Katsuki said softly. "We'll figure something out. After we get the kids to safety, it'll be smooth sailing. We'll have our whole lives ahead of us after that and then who knows what type of life we'll get this round."

Izuku's brows pinched together. "Type of life?"

"The disappearance program, it gives you a new life," Katsuki explained. He picked up a broken twig and casually tossed it into the lake, creating new ripples. "It'll help give you a fresh start. You'll be a whole new person without worrying about your past catching up to you."

“Would we be able to choose what type of life?” Izuku asked quietly.

“I dunno.” Katsuki sat up right a little more, elated to sense a hint of curiosity from Izuku. “But if you could, what would you choose?”

“I don’t know,” Izuku whispered. “I never thought about what I would do if I gave up this life.”

“Think about it now. Take your time.”

Izuku hummed and he stared at the ripples in the water. Then he turned his eyes up to the scarlet leaves that were encasing them. He smiled with a faraway gaze. “I would…be a violin player.”

“Good choice,” Katsuki whispered.

“What about you, Kacchan? What would you choose?”

Izuku turned towards Katsuki and there was a sliver of hope shining through his eyes. Katsuki grinned with all his teeth and leaned in to brush their shoulders together.

“Easy. I would be a music composer.”

“But if we don’t get that, what else would you be?”

“I suppose, in another life, I would only want to be with you.” The words flowed easily off Katsuki’s tongue and Izuku’s eyes filled with affection. “It wouldn’t matter what we are or what we were doing. We could be normal, everyday people with regular jobs.”

“Maybe you’d be a good handyman.” Izuku smiled tenderly. “Or a detective.”

Katsuki made a disgusted face. “In no fucking life would I ever be a cop.”

“Fair,” Izuku chuckled, mood finally lifting. “I think then you would be a great photographer. Or, if we were choosing anything, you’d be a wonderful pro fighter. You would be the number one champion. Maybe even a misunderstood pirate who hunts for treasure like in one of my books.”

Katsuki smiled at that. “You’d be a great baker.”

“I burn every ounce of food I touch.” Izuku shook his head. “I have never cooked before Okinawa.”

“Okay fine.” Katsuki laughed. “What about a gardener? You could have a backyard full of roses that you sell.”

“I also have a terrible green thumb.” Izuku smiled a little bit more. He playfully pulled at a springy curl on his head. “The only thing green about me is my eyes and hair.”

“And I love that,” Katsuki grinned wider when Izuku blushed pink. “I can picture it now: we start our new life, and we open up a flower shop together. It’s quiet and no one knows who we are. We’re simply known as the nice married couple who sells half dead roses.”

Izuku laughed loudly, nose scrunching with the thought. “And people would come in confused, but they still buy a bouquet because of your threatening stare.”

“Or they would buy it because they’re charmed by your sweetness,” Katsuki countered. “We would have great sales every day if you smiled at everyone and spoke to them in that gentle voice you use on me sometimes.”

“Hm, I can see that.” Izuku beamed. “Then after we made all these sales, we’d go home and laugh about it.”

“I would cook dinner and you would prepare for the next day.”

“After that we would go to the couch and snuggle,”

“With a big fuzzy blanket. I would watch TV while you read a book.”

“And after a while, I would fall asleep in your arms.”

“Then we’d do it all over again the next day.”

Izuku began laughing fully, voice in tune with the bright light around them.

It was a beautiful sight. Izuku seemed carefree thinking about a future that was worth reaching out for. Katsuki willed that Izuku was truly cracking and moving on his stance. Then slowly, the harmonious laughs bled into tiny, sharp breaths. Then the breaths gradually became soft cries and Izuku’s face was bruised with raw intensity, like his illusion was broken.

“Th-That would be nice,” Izuku said in a broken voice. “W-Wouldn’t it?”

Katsuki turned his body towards Izuku, and he took his hand.

He looked at their wedding bands and slowly it all came together. It fit like shattered stones that still had gaps but against all odds fit together in many ways. And he liked that because Katsuki always considered himself broken too. He was bred in a broken home. Raised by broken parents. Took on a broken fucking sense of a job.

His idea of love was even broken.

Everything he touched bled because he was a sharp, shattered man that was not able to fit together with anyone. However, with Izuku, his broken jagged edges never were a problem. Izuku was equally as broken and because of that, they somehow fit together. No matter the lifetime.

“I love you, Izuku,” Katsuki confessed.

Izuku's eyes softened, and his tears poured like that was the final weight to break him.

"I love you too, Katsuki," Izuku confessed back.

Katsuki's heart soared higher than it ever did. He touched the clouds at the same moment Izuku touched him. Scarred hands cupped his cheeks and pulled him in for a kiss. Izuku was hesitant for valid reasons, but his love shone through. Warmth entrapped them as he kissed Izuku back tender yet fiercely in an attempt to devour. He wanted to communicate that this was it for him.

Izuku was his and he was Izuku's.

☽ ☽ ☽

They were back to normal after they exchanged 'I love you's.

Katsuki could've been fooled. It was almost like that weird week didn't happen. There was no more talk about divorces or leaving. Izuku was enjoying their time together and Katsuki enjoyed it as well. This gave Katsuki hope that Izuku was potentially considering their options.

In the quiet nights while Izuku was passed out, Katsuki shifted through that black folder. Aizawa was right, this information was old. Many of the phone numbers that were listed inside were cut off, or dead ends. It made Katsuki frustrated, because he could feel himself pressed for time, but he worked relentlessly on figuring out how to find Nana.

Izuku didn't mention leaving again, however.

His quietness washed over the last few days, and they went back to their normal, happy routine. Every day they exchanged kisses, playfully teased each other, and enjoyed romantic dinners.

The first week after their confession, they traveled around like they used to.

He happily gave Izuku piggyback rides and they stole tiny kisses all throughout the day. They finished completing the list of restaurants Katsuki wanted to taste test and Izuku circled a couple that were his favorite.

"You should come back to these," Izuku said happily. "They're so good!"

Katsuki taped the list to the fridge the next day.

☽ ☽ ☽

The second week after their confessions, Katsuki gave composing a song a try.

He had been in classes for a while now, and he wanted to give it a shot. He wrote something inspired by Izuku. It was soft, yet sharp. Mysterious yet vulnerable. He felt like this encompassed both sides of his husband, and how he always had so many intriguing aspects about him. He wrote it for a violin solo.

Izuku played it happily in the music room. He moved his bow across that old, white violin with an unnamed passion. His eyes were closed most of the time, but when they were open, he maintained enchanting eye contact with Katsuki.

“You’re going to make the most beautiful songs,” Izuku said like he was deeply in love. “I can’t wait to hear what you create.”

After that, Katsuki constructed a series of violin solos dedicated to Izuku.

They were songs that encompassed how he felt about Izuku at different stages of his life.

The first was a tender song, dedicated to their time in Tokyo. It was filled with childhood naivety and wonder. The next songs were a fury of sharp notes and an underlying sensation of lust for their rivalry years. The following set was for their time in Okinawa, relaxing and encompassing their epiphany after being separated for so long.

Then the final songs were reflective of their time here, at the estate. Slow, vulnerable. He tried his best to capture what falling in love sounded like to him.

Izuku played each one, and Katsuki pinned the music sheets up on the wall. He realized Izuku somehow became his muse amongst the many other labels he had in their web of connection. His savior. His childhood friend. His inspiration. His past rival. His husband.

In this lifetime, Izuku seemed to be his everything.

All roads led to Izuku.

☽ ☽ ☽

The third week after their confessions, they watched a string of Izuku’s favorite romance movies.

They snuggled up on the couch every night and Izuku showed him all the reasons why these particular films he adored more than others. He analyzed the movies down to the very last montage, saying that nothing was done at random.

Katsuki didn’t feel any disgust for romance while watching.

He smiled at it the whole time, happy that he finally found what he was looking for.

☽ ☽ ☽

The fourth week after their confessions, Izuku helped him plant a bundle of pink carnations in the backyard.

They put it next to the garden, but still far away enough from the house that it wasn’t always such a painful reminder. For this Katsuki was grateful, and Izuku’s thoughtfulness was always a quality that he loved about him.

All the sweet moments lulled him enough to refocus on enjoying Izuku's time here. While he did that though, he was tirelessly figuring out where the hell Shimura Nana was located.

Currently, Katsuki was flipping through the black folder in bed.

He had set up several pins in a map of all the places that Nana was last. He was piecing together her new location that was deeply coded. It wasn't straight forward, which Katsuki gave Nana props for. In case this fell into the wrong hands, she wouldn't be an easy find.

He concluded that she didn't stay around in the same city for long, and whenever she potentially made people disappear, she did as well. Her previous alias was Float and now he was attempting to figure out the new alias that was needed to specify before talking to her.

So far he decoded two words: One. All.

He was close to figuring out the third. Once he pieced together all the combinations—he would go to Nana and tell her about Izuku.

Speaking of Izuku, the other man wasn't with him. His husband had said he wanted to read on the patio to amplify his reading experience. Sounded like a nerdy thing to do, and Katsuki smiled at the thought. Izuku gave him a quick kiss on the lips and ran off with his book, giddy like always.

When their usual bedtime arrived, Izuku wandered back into their bedroom, stretching lightly and yawned.

Katsuki couldn't help but note how he was walking now.

No cast. No limp.

But still no mention of leaving.

"Did you enjoy reading your book?" Katsuki asked.

He put the black folder on the nightstand to give Izuku all his attention. Green eyes flickered to the black folder and then back to Katsuki with a loving smile.

Izuku nodded sweetly. "I did. The rain really made me feel like I was in the atmosphere. Only thing that would have made it better was if you read it to me, Kacchan."

"I can read a chapter to you tonight, if you really want." Katsuki smiled back at him. "I'm happy you're enjoying all those novels. They were super hard to find, turns out you're not the only nerd fighting to read those sappy books."

Izuku climbed in the bed and snuggled closely to him. "Thank you again for finding those for me."

Katsuki snaked an arm around Izuku's waist. "Of course. Anything for you, darling."

Izuku's eyes flashed with something at the mention of 'darling'. He smiled gentler and his eyes became shinier in the dim, bedroom light. His hand pushed forward, touching Katsuki's cheek bone. He grazed it so lightly Katsuki questioned if he really touched him. The simple motion stole his breath away in a way only Izuku could.

Katsuki turned his body inwards to him and smiled lovingly with half hooded eyes. Izuku then cupped his cheek and leaned their foreheads together.

"I love you so much," Izuku whispered.

"I love you too, darling," Katsuki muttered back.

He pulled Izuku tightly to him and both of their eyes naturally closed. These were some of Katsuki's favorite moments, the tenderness they shared at night. Their limbs tangled and the light touch of Izuku's eyelashes could be felt on his cheek.

Katsuki kissed Izuku softly.

Izuku kissed him back slowly.

Katsuki opened his mouth and tilted Izuku's head when he tasted a hint of sweetness. Izuku pushed into the kiss, as if he needed to be a part of him. His hands gripped Katsuki's shirt and Katsuki was swept under the feeling of Izuku's tongue swiping against his. Katsuki bit at Izuku's bottom lip when he could taste that hidden saccharine once more. He smiled. Izuku's sweet tooth was always a small benefit for moments like this.

They broke apart and Izuku was smiling sadly at him.

Katsuki's head felt slightly light.

He tried to think through the mild sway of his vision, but any logic was drowned when Izuku kissed him again, several times deeper. It was as if they were melting into it. Then Katsuki's cheeks felt rosy and warm. When he tried to open his eyes again, his eyelids were heavy—and this time the room did blur.

His vision swarmed. Izuku's lovely freckles were unclear.

"Iz—" Katsuki's eyes widened when his tongue was heavy. He grasped urgently at Izuku's shirt; fist tight. "Iz-Izuku—"

Izuku held his hand.

Tears now poured out his beautiful green eyes and they dropped directly onto him. Izuku broke down and all Katsuki wanted to say was *"don't cry",* but he was unable to form the words. His mouth was numb. His hands were numb. His legs were too. His grip on Izuku's shirt went slack and his arm dropped hard onto the mattress like it was lifeless.

Katsuki tried to shake his head when it became clear what was happening. He laid there, trapped in his unmovable body staring up at Izuku who was breaking down, face crumbled up like all their dreams of a future together.

“My time is up,” Izuku’s voice cracked. “I’m sorry, Kacchan. I love you so much.”

A lone tear escaped out of Katsuki’s eye as his vision was engulfed in darkness.

☽ ☽ ☽

When Katsuki awoke, all his worst fears came true.

Izuku was gone.

“The problem was you,” his self-doubt murmured. “You were not a good enough person for him to stay.”

“Even if he does love you, he left,” his anxiety muttered. “You woke up alone.”

“You’re unlovable,” his self-hatred stated cruelly. “He could never love a monster like you.”

He called out for Izuku’s name, stumbling upright in their room—or what was their room.

When his feet hit the floor, his world shifted, and he immediately became nauseated. His knees buckled easier than they should have as he went tumbling down. He heaved, clutching at his stomach and then finally he was pulled by pain to lay flat on the ground. Lightheadedness overtook him and it was difficult to think straight.

He had been poisoned.

He touched his lips in disbelief.

It must’ve been a toxin harmless enough to knock him out for several hours and paralyze him.

It was a smart choice because if Katsuki’s motor functions were at his full capabilities, he would’ve chased after Izuku. He would get his tracking gear and begin to hunt that fucking man down and stop him before he got back to Tokyo. He would prevent him from disappearing into the binding grip of the shadows.

But instead, Katsuki cried on the floor as his limbs felt heavy like lead.

He clawed at the hard surface in defeat and sobbed ugly sounds he never knew he could make.

“Izuku,” Katsuki gasped. His voice was groggy, and all the syllables of his lover’s name were broken like his heart. “…*Izuku*.”

He cried harder than he had ever before because he was truly alone.

The memories of their time together were the only thing cradling him. He called out Izuku’s name. He called out Deku. He even sobbed out Darling in hopes that this was all a bad dream. How had he squandered all their borrowed time? He dragged himself with his forearms, trying to will the function to return to his body.

All he could see now was his beautiful Izuku shackled and chained to the goddamn academy, and Katsuki's heart was pained beyond words. He had to find him. He had to. He fucking had to—but he *couldn't* right now with the poison still coursing through his veins.

He cried for hours, from what he could tell.

He wondered if he could cry out the poison through his tear drops that fell solemnly to the ground. After what felt like eternity, the feeling in his limbs returned to him. They loosened as if he was growing wings, and when he stood up the weight in his ribcage was the heaviest stone inside of him.

He dragged himself towards the door, unsure why.

Maybe Izuku was there, waiting paralyzed like he had been.

However, when he reached the front area, he found nothing.

Nothing. Nothing. *Nothing*.

He was going to let his tears come again and fall deep into the pit that was opening up at the bottom of him.

However, before he could do that, he turned his head. He frowned when there was a red folder sitting there on his wooden table. It was neatly placed and stationed directly out in the open. Katsuki whirled around, confused. He stumbled as he checked for someone else, potentially an agent from The Company—but he was as alone as he feared he would be.

He looked back at the folder again, curious to how it got there.

Then when he studied it closer, it wasn't a red folder from The Company. It possessed a Viper seal—exactly the same as the red folder Izuku had showed him so long ago in Okinawa.

Katsuki walked towards it, compelled by an unknown force.

His tears halted momentarily in his confusion as he arrived in front of it.

With steady hands, he picked the folder up. It was torn open like someone rushed to see what was inside, beating him to it. The wax viper seal was cracked down the middle and a collection of dried tear stains were sitting on top.

He flipped it open and went rigid.

Awaiting inside was a text document and stapled to it was exactly three photos.

The first photo was of a man Katsuki had met only once.

He had frigid golden eyes, and reddish-brown hair. He was dressed in a perfectly spotless black suit and his pale face was pristine in a way only well-preserved art could be. It was the Yakuza heir, Mr. Chisaki, that had been walking out of Aizawa's office—right before the Chizome incident.

The next photo was of Izuku.

His green eyes were glazed over, showing nothing inside like two bottomless pits. His hair was longer, curlier and wilder. He stared into the camera like he was seeing through a ghost as he wore a metal mask over the lower half of his face.

And the last photo was of his mother.

She was happily walking around—a photograph captured from far away. And from the looks of it, this was taken from around the same year she was killed. In her hands was a large bouquet of pink carnations, possibly directly after Katsuki had given them to her. She was smiling at the flowers like there wasn't a care in the world.

But it wasn't the pictures that haunted Katsuki. It was the words that tied them all together.

The words painted a picture more agonizing than anything he ever encountered.

He read them over and over again as the truth soaked in.

Mark: Bakugou Mitsuki

Requester: Chisaki Kai

Assassin: The Viridian Viper

Requestor Details: Mark fled Tokyo several years ago with dramatic debt. She stole money and jewelry after staying underneath the shelter of the Yakuza for a full year. In all attempts to track her down or get her to repay, she fled or was unable to be found. Due to this, Yakuza Heir, Chisaki Kai, no longer wishes to collect her debt, but rather close the loose end.

Assignment details: Mark was home alone cleaning in an apartment with an open window. Viper stationed himself across the way on another rooftop with a sniper gun and fully concealed. Task was completed with no casualties or witnesses with a single bullet.

Katsuki's heart drummed faster and faster until it broke in half.

He had never had a broken heart before, and it rocked his being like nothing he ever experienced. His world was torn and burning at the edges, slowly consuming him until there was nothing left. White noise cut through his ears and into his skin. Everything was all too much to process because it stung.

It fucking *hurt* and his heart squeezed until he couldn't breathe. Choppy breaths escaped him and all the shattered pieces of himself demolished further. He wilted in disbelief as visions of Izuku smiling at him rampaged his memory.

Izuku left this.

Izuku left *this*. Which meant—

Did he know this whole time?

Katsuki's mind went blank with searing hot pain. It was as if he was being hit with their memories over and over again until all his nerve endings swelled with a numbing sensation. Every smile, kiss, and promise felt like a lash of agony as it beat against his heart.

He choked back sobs as he stared at that void on Izuku's face, the loving expression on his mother's, and then finally the fucking disgustingly smug expression of Chisaki's.

Within mere seconds, Katsuki was transported back to her apartment on that day years ago.

He was soaked in her blood again and he could feel the wetness seeping through his clothes. He was weeping over her body that had a bullet hole pouring out red. However, this time, he could see Izuku standing in front of him. His husband was holding the smoking gun with that bottomless pit of nothingness in his beautiful eyes.

The dormant darkness inside of Katsuki viciously snarled and snapped its sharp teeth. The entity melted with the part of him that loved Izuku so deeply. Clashing emotions melded into one, truly testing the thin line between love and hate until his darkness became a gigantic beast too overwhelming for him to contain.

Katsuki gripped the folder until his fingers tore through it and his nails pierced his skin.

His palms bled all over the photos, dark red pooled over Izuku's face. Drip by drip his thick blood soaked the photo, and it gave him pause. He studied how Izuku's face was drowned in red. The same way his mother's had been.

All roads led to Izuku.

As Katsuki stared at the photograph, his darkness and the part of him that loved Izuku agreed on one thing: **devour him.**

Chapter End Notes

Let me know what you think below! *hides slightly* I was very eager to get to this part of the story and the first of many pivot points ^^

Thank you so much for reading! This is officially a wrap for Katsuki's POV (for now) :) next up is Izuku's side of the coin!! Thank's so much for sticking around this much in the story. I didn't anticipate it to be this long but I am really enjoying the world building and storylines that intersect.

Chapter 17: Entr'acte I

Chapter Summary

> Entr'acte: an interval between two acts of a play or opera. - Izuku's POV beginning

Chapter Notes

> Helloooo! Welcome back to this lair of angst!! We're officially kicking off with Izuku's POV on the sunshine boy's birthday :') I love him so much! *gives him 23k worth of angst* I hope you enjoy this as we now dive into Izuku's mindset and POV as much as we did Katsuki's! It's been a fun time writing this.
>
> Big thank you to Luna, the LOML for betaing like always ^^ She's amazing! Please do glance at the warning list as we move on. This warning list will apply to all the Entr'acte chapters (Izuku's past unraveling + the mysterious murder of Bakugou Mitsuki) :D
>
> Alrighy! Enjoy!
>
> **Warnings: Homicide, Extreme gaslighting, Manipulation, Child abuse, Child death, Character Death, Abuse in general. Forced Killing. Mind games. Graphic Violence. Human trafficking. Use of needles. Overall darker themes and concepts.**

See the end of the chapter for more notes



Chapter 17 — Entr'acte I

.

.

.

12 years before incident

Izuku had to hurry.

His vision was blurry as he pushed past the tall adults in the crowded streets of Tokyo. He wiped a trickle of blood off his chin that dripped down from his split lip. The winter winds nipped at his face, making his skin rosy as he ran directly for the carnival.

In his head, he recalled the very reason why he was late: his big brother.

Tomura had turned thirteen and gotten taken somewhere. When he returned, there was blood caked on his face and his eyes were strangely wide. Uneasy quietness emitted from his hunched figure as he muttered. It worried Izuku how still and silent he was being. So Izuku reached his hand out, only wanting to pull his brother back to focus—but Tomura flinched and punched him.

Izuku went tumbling backwards, caught off guard by the sudden attack. Then right as he put his arms up to protect himself, the dresser drawers when flying everywhere. Their mirror was bashed against the wall. But Tomura's fit of rage wasn't towards him—it was directed elsewhere.

Izuku cowardly stood in the corner as the red light in their room started flashing. Tomura's laughs and cries mixed together in an unsettling rotation that made Izuku unsure exactly what was going on. Izuku cried and kept banging the button for their caretakers to come.

When the caretakers arrived, Izuku was too terrified to move. He watched as Tomura was dragged off, still crying and laughing in a strange harmony. Izuku couldn't leave as he was questioned for hours and assessed for any damage. He had what the adults called a fractured nose.

He was instructed by his floor's parents to go to the infirmary after their nightly check in. She led him down to the basement level and then left to tend to Tomura. When she was out of sight, Izuku left the waiting lobby and ran straight for his exit.

Which is how he came to be three hours late meeting Kacchan.

By the time he arrived, Izuku was out of breath and a sinking feeling was overpowering him. Every light at the carnival was turned off. The crowds were gone. The lights were dim. No joyous laughter or fun songs surrounded him like it should've.

His eyes widely searched around in the nothingness, afraid that he might've hurt Kacchan's feelings.

Kacchan didn't like to be alone. It always made him cry.

“Kacchan?” Izuku called. “Kacchan, where are you? ‘m sorry about being late!”

He wandered a bit, tiny boots crunching the snow. However, as he walked around no one was there. The carnival was closed and the only thing greeting him were steel bars wrapped around the entire perimeter.

Izuku sadly looked down at his watch and saw the time. 22:23.

Kacchan would’ve gone back to the nook by now. Izuku knew he needed to go see him and explain why he was late so Kacchan’s feelings wouldn’t be too hurt.

Izuku turned on his heels and took off.

Along the way he held his glove up to his nose, soaking up all the dripping blood that fell out. Some droplets hit the fresh, white snow leaving a stark scarlet trail where he walked. He trudged along, willingly ignoring that it was past 22:22 for once in his life.

When he arrived at the abandoned church, he stared at it with hope. He crawled through the small hole off the side like it was second nature and hurried past the cracks and cobwebs. He sprinted straight for the nook and swung open the door.

Izuku stopped.

The small boy whirled around, confused. He stared at the heap of blankets as if the tattered sheets might move and reveal his best friend. He then turned his eyes on the unpacked clothes and the discarded comics lying around. Izuku scooted in further, wondering maybe he was misunderstanding what he was seeing. He felt out the pillows and lifted under the blanket calling out his friend’s name. But it was no use.

Kacchan wasn’t there.

ᔓᔓᔓ

“Okay, ’s no worries,” Izuku muttered to himself as he began walking home. His heart was pounding out of sync. “H-He probably is still walking ‘round. I’ll see ‘im tomorrow and then we will leave for the sunny place.”

Izuku spent a while trying to convince himself that everything was fine.

He reasoned that Kacchan’s boots, hat, gloves and coat were gone. This had to mean he can’t be far. Maybe Kacchan was upset that he was late, and they hadn’t been able to go to the carnival together like they promised. He probably was storming around the city with his frown and big pout.

The young Izuku thought this all to himself as he turned into the dark alley. He thought this as he went straight for the back of a building that no longer was used for anything. Right there was his passage home, a small manhole with the design of a flower encrusted in the metal.

Izuku hooked his fingers inside and lifted with effort. He huffed and planted his small feet firm in the snow as he moved the heavy lid to the side. He was happy his big brother made him do extra lifts during moments like this.

He climbed down into the deafening darkness as all the sounds and lights from Tokyo were engulfed by the passage. He pulled the lid, gritting his teeth as it dragged against the concrete until it shut tight over him. Izuku continued to make his way down into the hole, his only light now being his yellow watch.

The number 23:10 was staring back at him.

He grunted as he hopped down onto the barren concrete underneath. There were no souls or sounds down here. He sometimes swore he heard the fluttering of moths hover too close to his ears as he walked.

Izuku's eyes adjusted to the darkness, and he could see the dimly lit underground.

All around were tall, mythical like pillars that supported the massive structure. He thought them to be similar to the figures he heard of in books, maybe the ones deserving of praise because they were so large and impossible. It was like a temple underground and it reminded Izuku just how small he was every time he passed through here.

This used to be a part of the underground Tokyo flood system, Izuku learned once in their lessons about the city.

It was abandoned during construction because this section was nine layers deep versus the five the architects decided to settle on. It reached too far and was ultimately barred off from the main flood system and public. Now it served as a pointless layer underneath Tokyo. An endless labyrinth of large tunnels that twisted upon themselves into a maze.

Izuku had been pulled by his curiosity so much that he decided to go seek it out. He had only wanted to explore it, amazed by how vast the underground flood system was in his home city. He was unsure of where this road would take him but luckily for him—one day it led him to Kacchan.

Izuku easily navigated the pathway home in the dark.

A couple of twists and turns then he was placed beneath his home. He climbed through a tiny tunnel that put him out to the basement of The Academy. It was a small vent that led out into the underground.

Whoever placed this building here didn't think about setting it on top of this forgotten system, luckily for him. Extra lucky for him, the gateway was underneath the tiles and hidden away. He had stumbled across it on a stroke of good fortune when he picked up on the hollowed sound beneath his feet once.

Izuku quietly peeled back the loose tile and peeked his head up from the ground. No one was around. Izuku quickly crawled out, squeezing his body through the square shaped hole in the

floor. He gingerly placed the loose tile back over his passageway and smiled when it fit like a glove.

He looked at the time again. 23:40.

He hurried and took off his winter boots and coat. He reached for where he had stowed away his yellow backpack and shoved the articles of clothing inside sloppily. He was left only dressed in his regular all black school uniform and switched out his boots for his school issued leather shoes.

Izuku took a deep breath and made his way out of the compact room. He glanced around the dark hallways that were entirely empty save for the sound of strange sobbing through the vents. He ignored it, like he always did and snuck his way to the staircase.

He climbed up all the endless flights of metallic stairs with his pulse racing.

He stopped when he arrived at the level that read ‘10’ in dark green paint. Izuku shimmied the lock a bit, then pulled out a small, pointed knife to jam into the lock carefully. The moment the lock popped he pulled the door open and peeked around.

The shiny, sterile hallways were devoid of any presence. All the lights were off, and the countless rows of doors were shut. Izuku crept slowly, being careful not to make a sound as he walked. He reached the door that read two name plates: ‘117’ on a golden plaque and ‘Izuku’ on a silver one.

Izuku tapped his little yellow watch against a green censor to open the door.

The large room was cleaned up, as if nothing had happened. The glass from the broken mirror was gone. His bed was made up. Tomura was even inside of his own bed across the way, neatly tucked in and turned away from him. Izuku walked in quietly, placing his coat and shoes up at the front of their room.

He tiptoed in, careful as he passed Tomura who was unbearably still. His brother’s short hair showed the base of his neck and his mark ‘117’. Izuku changed into his pajamas without a sound, and then got underneath the covers.

“It took them that long to tend to your nose?” Tomura asked, jolting Izuku.

“I thought you were ‘sleep,” Izuku muttered in the dark. His heart began pounding in his chest and he clutched the edge of his comforter.

“I couldn’t sleep until I knew you were coming back.” Tomura didn’t face him. There was a sadness in his voice that clutched Izuku. “Is your nose alright?”

Izuku shifted quietly. “It’s fine.”

“Good.” A pause. “Sorry for…what happened.”

Izuku didn’t know how to reply. Tomura was a lot of things: smart, quick, and frightening—but sorry was never one.

“My nose will be ‘kay,” Izuku settled on.

An irritated huff left Tomura. “We need to hurry up and fix that lisp of yours before it becomes a problem with Ms. Nagant.”

Izuku nodded in the dark and Tomura didn’t give him anything more.

Silence followed them and Izuku turned over in the large bed. He looked out the window that was next to him sadly, gazing upon the lights.

From up here, the city looked like a bundle of neon stars. All the blending shades of blue and violet were sparkling like a fairy tale. Izuku stared down at the winding roads and twisting sidewalks, searching if he could see a blond head of hair from far up here. He always wondered what it might be like to live amongst the crowds below, but tonight he only wondered if Kacchan was down there as well.

Izuku gazed down at his watch to see the numbers 00:00.



When Izuku awoke it was 06:00 sharp, like always.

The two alarm clocks in the room buzzed loudly at the same time the sun hit his face. When he arose from his bed, Tomura was already up like usual. His big brother never bothered with combing his hair and his smooth skin was always perfect and ready to go in the morning. He was fixing up the golden buttons on their uniforms and sliding on his shoes.

Izuku stared around their room, slightly still asleep. At night he could barely see much but with the sun, their sanctuary was vibrant.

Both of them had large queen-sized beds with tall canopies that surrounded them. There were matching wooden desks, closets and dressers. The ceiling was high with rows of lights, but only next to Izuku’s bed were large windows giving a perfect view of Tokyo. The dark green curtains were always pulled back by golden ropes and the wooden floorboards were covered up with a large black rug.

“Get out of bed, Izuku,” Tomura muttered without looking at him. “You’ve been sitting there dazed for a minute now.”

Izuku rubbed the sleep out of his eye and hopped up. He showered. Brushed his teeth. Combed his hair so he wouldn’t be made fun of for it. He got dressed and Tomura rolled the sleeves on his uniform for him to make it look less big.

“You’re smaller than you should be,” Tomura noted unhappily. “When I was your age I filled this out fine. You really are the runt of the pack.”

Izuku felt ashamed.

He looked down at his tiny hand and he knew his brother was right. But Izuku didn't stay too sad about himself for long. On the front of his mind was Kacchan and he tried to hide the knots in his stomach. Izuku told himself not to worry, they were married, and married people always found each other.

At 06:30 he and Tomura were gathered by their floor's parent, Tsutsumi Kaina as usual. She always insisted she be called Ms. Nagant though. Izuku never understood why, but he did it.

"117. Izuku. Are you ready?" She called through the door.

They were, of course. Tomura made sure they were standing by the door ready to go at 06:28 sharp.

They stepped out in their matching uniforms and dark green backpacks. Above their hearts were words Izuku didn't really understand. On Tomura's it said, 'Phase Three' and on Izuku's it said 'Phase One'. Beneath the lettering was an embroidered symbol of a snake with sharp fangs prepared to attack.

"Good morning Ms. Nagant," both Izuku and Tomura said in unison.

Ms. Nagant was perfectly dressed in her all-white uniform. She didn't smile at them, which was no surprise. Izuku could count on one hand how many times she had smiled. It had been once, when she watched a man trip on the sidewalk from her office window. Besides that, small blip of joy, her dark eyes never showed a gateway to any positive emotions.

She reached a hand out and grabbed Izuku's jaw. He didn't say a word as she tilted it from side to side, staring hard at his swollen nose.

Izuku stared at her face as she did this, curious. Below her left eye was her mark: 21.

She sharply cut her eyes to Tomura, who was staring down at the floor.

"You're not going to have another outburst, are you?" Ms. Nagant asked slowly. "We don't need you accidentally killing him. That would be a big headache for everyone."

"I'm under control," Tomura muttered.

Izuku glanced his eyes down to Tomura's curled fists behind his back.

"Good," Ms. Nagant said, with authority deep in her voice. "If you have another meltdown like that, we're going to have to take you downstairs to the testing facilities to assess you for defects."

Tomura nodded stiffly.

"And *you*," Ms. Nagant hissed, gripping Izuku's jaw tighter until he winced. She glowered. "Cowering in the corner until someone arrived was disgusting. Next time, fight back. I'm marking you down for this."

Izuku stiffly nodded in her grasp. "Y-Yes, Ms. Nagant."

Her frown deepened at his stuttering.

“Glad you’re both in check,” she said as kindly as she could. “Now get to the back of the line.”

Tomura and Izuku did as she said, filing in neatly with the several rows of other kids in pairs.

As they went to the back of the line, he could hear several snickers from the other kids. Izuku tried his best not to shy away.



They walked through the beautiful hallways of their home, and this was the only moment of peace Izuku really knew in the daylight.

Everything was a sterile white, contrasting their black uniforms. Pretty, green plants aligned the marble hallways. On the walls were beautiful paintings of various types of snakes reflecting the fluorescent light. Izuku would play a game in his mind as he tried to name the different types as they walked. Copperhead. Cottonmouth. Rattlesnakes. Horned. He didn’t know all of them, but he knew some.

He wondered if he would miss doing this when he left Tokyo soon.

Along the way they passed glass study rooms that showed other siblings from different floors. In one box two kids were fencing. In another a girl with long green hair was solemnly practicing her fighting stances. In another, one sibling was knife throwing at targets. All their usual activities.

When they arrived at the cafeteria at 07:00, they ate quickly.

There was never room to dabble or chat. They were given their golden trays full of food and vitamins. If Izuku was caught daydreaming, Tomura would flick him in the cheek and point down to his smoothie.

“Make sure you drink every last drop of that,” Tomura would scold. “It’s the most important part of the meal.”

Because of Tomura’s warnings, Izuku always made sure to drink his green smoothie, no matter how much it made his stomachache some days.

After that, they walked down just as neatly to the classrooms for the 07:30 lessons to begin.

From here, they were neatly sectioned off like various assortments of coins.

The older kids, like Tomura, were placed in a different room. Izuku noticed how all of them had their marks already. 101. 116. 128. 119. He wondered if sadness came with these marks, because after all the big brothers and sisters got them—they seemed different.

The younger kids, like himself, were kept in various classrooms. The classrooms were large and full of white desks, white boards, white chairs. The windows were blocked out with sheer white curtains so they wouldn't get distracted by looking out the window. On the walls were posts with various equations and characters from the different languages they were learning.

Izuku walked into the classroom slowly, with his head down. He heard some snickering immediately and didn't need to lift up his eyes to know who was laughing at him.

"The runt lives to see another day," the voice of Sen said. "I heard a rumor that Tomura might have smashed your head in. I was hoping it would be true."

Izuku turned his head unwillingly when a chorus of snickers arose.

Sen was sitting with his legs kicked up on the desk and an arrogant smirk on his face. His chocolate brown hair was a mess, and his deep brown eyes were burning into him. Next to him was Himiko, with her blonde hair and bright gleaming golden eyes. She was grinning as sharp as knives with other students as they eyed Izuku up and down.

Izuku got that knot in his tummy he always did when they would stare at him like that.

He quickly turned his eyes forward and walked swiftly to his seat. He took his station in the front today, not wanting to deal with the kids who would turn around and shoot him weird faces. They did it in hopes of distracting him and getting him in trouble with the teacher, Sako Atsuhiro. Or as he liked to be called, Mr. Compress.

"Everyone take your seats," Mr. Compress called out in his usual friendly tone. He was one of their warmer parents, Izuku enjoyed his funny walk with his cane. "We'll begin with our Viper pledge. Now all repeat after me: I am useless."

"I am useless," the class echoed dutifully.

"I have no purpose," Mr. Compress continued and every word he spoke was given back to him. "I am lucky and grateful that I have been found by a family to take me in and give me purpose. I will not be weak. I will not be soft. I will not be kind because these are things that could hurt the family."

Everyone repeated what he said, believing the full sentient.

"Perfect!" Mr. Compress said happily. "We'll start today's lesson now! We'll be going over the geography of Tokyo and then dive into our Mandarin, Korean and English lessons."

All the students pulled out their textbooks and pencils.

As Mr. Compress started lecturing, Izuku stared a bit too hard at his neck. Imprinted on his skin in black ink like the other caretakers was the mark—his was 45.

Marks were a symbol of belonging, according to Mr. Compress.

They had a big event for getting them: The Cull.

Every year, everyone who turned ten got to participate in it. If any of them got the mark they were *officially* a part of the Mamushi family. If they failed to get it, then that person would be kicked out of their paradise to live a terrible life in the cruel outside world.

The outside world was terrible and the people in it lived horribly. There were no meals every day. No shelter and warm beds. There weren't any language lessons and fighting lessons. Because of this people on the outside lied, tricked others, and were often violently jealous of one another. It was a vicious cycle that bred endless tragedy in the world.

However, their sanctuary kept them away from all of that.

Here they had food, water, warm beds and school. Everything they needed was here according to all their caretakers, but they would have to prove if they were worthy of it once they turned ten.

Izuku didn’t believe that the outside was all that terrible until he saw how Kacchan lived. The people in that alley seemed so unhappy, cold, and miserable.

But most days Izuku felt like that too. He cried often, bled just as much. He was lonely and he was terrified of Tomura, Himiko and Sen. He used to want to do well at The Cull in order for everyone to stop picking on him.

But now he wasn’t sure after he met Kacchan. Kacchan liked him without the mark, so why did he need it? Because of this, Izuku didn’t think bringing Kacchan here was still the best choice. All he could see was Himiko, Sen or Jin trying to beat up Kacchan until he bled like they did frequently to him.

But once they were on that train, marks wouldn’t matter. Family wouldn’t matter. Fitting in wouldn’t matter. He was going to leave with Kacchan, the best person in the world, and he wouldn’t *need* to be accepted.

Him and Kacchan were going to take care of each other, and they would live happily ever after like those romance people.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When the midday break came, it was exactly 12:00.

All the classrooms let out and they always were allowed to choose how they spent the next hour. Many Bigs gathered their Littles during this time and took them for more lessons and food. Others talked amongst themselves and joked.

For Izuku, well. He usually was alone.

It wasn’t that Tomura disliked him. It was the opposite actually. Tomura cared for him a lot—but Tomura needed his alone time ever since he turned ten to help manage his stress. If he didn’t get alone time, then he would be prone to vicious outbursts like the one that broke Izuku’s nose. Or the moment where Tomura was stressed that Izuku missed check in and

lashed out terribly enough to break his arm. Or the time Tomura almost poked out his eye with the knives.

Tomura was always halfway himself during these times. When he settled back into his mind, he would tell Izuku he needed to get tougher so he could defend himself.

Izuku would nod but never really try to be tougher. He had no real need to train anymore since he was leaving with Kacchan. Izuku smiled a bit to himself at the memory of Kacchan kissing his cheek.

In place of spending time with his big brother, Izuku would go grab his favorite fruit and sit out in the courtyard during their breaks.

The courtyard was in the center of their home. The shape of their home was a hollowed-out triangle, with a large courtyard in the vacant area. It was filled with tall trees, pretty flowers, garden bushes and various athletic activities for all of them to enjoy. Izuku's favorite part is that it was big enough that he felt like he wasn't always crammed inside.

However, when he looked on all three sides, the tall building was towering over him large enough to be a wall. He supposed this was almost like freedom—not quite but close. He looked up towards the sky, and the glass roof over their head was protecting them from the snow and outside weather.

He hoped Kacchan was staying warm. Maybe they should pack an extra blanket.

Izuku ate his food on a bench far off in the corner. This was his favorite spot because it was secluded and he had the perfect view of one of their big brothers, Hiryu.

Hiryu was fifteen years old, strong, and he moved as graceful as a dancer whenever he practiced his martial arts. His long black hair flowed like beautiful, spilled ink in the wind and his body made so many interesting shapes as he kicked, punched and moved around the training grounds.

Next to Hiryu on a meditation mat was Tomura, reading up on one of their toxicology books.

As Izuku was appreciating a very intricate combo Hiryu performed, a wall of smaller bodies blocked his view. Izuku frowned deeply, swallowing the bit of banana he had bitten off.

"Hey, wittle '*zuku*," Himiko mocked. She waved and tilted her head with false innocence. "How was your day?"

Izuku kept his head down. He took another bite of his banana to help him not tremble.

He wouldn't miss this once he and Kacchan were off to Okinawa.

"C'mon, you're not going to talk?" Sen asked, a lot less nice than Himiko. "It's rude."

"My day 's fine…" Izuku mumbled.

As expected, all the kids laughed at his lisp. Izuku held back tears as he clutched the fruit in his hand. He glanced up to see their twisted faces leering at him.

In the background both Hiryu and Tomura stopped what they were doing and glanced over.

“You’re right, Himiko. He *does* still sound like a baby,” Sen sneered. He jammed his finger into Izuku’s swollen nose, making him flinch harshly. “A *weak* little baby.”

“Leave me alone,” Izuku snapped.

He swatted Sen’s hand that reached out to jab at his nose again. Which unfortunately earned him being grabbed by the wrists by Sen. Izuku yelped when the larger boy shook him, making all his food fall into the grass.

“Or what, *runt*?” Sen jeered. He leaned all the way into Izuku’s space, and it made Izuku shy away. “My big brother says I can push around weak people all I want. It’s what we’re going to do for the rest of our lives so why not start with you? You’ll *never* get your mark.”

“Sen. Himiko.” A loud, booming voice stopped everyone.

All eyes turned to the larger figure approaching. With a frown meant to make everyone halt was Hiryu stalking up to them. Sen dropped Izuku’s wrists, Himiko straightened out and Izuku quickly scrambled to pick up his fruit. He stopped midway when crawling ants were now making their way on top of the open banana. Izuku pulled his hand back into his lap.

“That’s enough,” Hiryu commanded forcefully. He glared down at all the young kids. “If I catch you again troubling Izuku, I’m going to report you to Nine.”

Nine.

That name alone was enough to make everyone in the vicinity stop.

Tomura was now paying full attention to them.

Sen, Himiko and the couple other kids there were clustered startled at the name drop. They backed up, but not before Sen shot Izuku a heated glare and stuck his tongue out at him. They scattered, going off elsewhere in the large courtyard out of sight.

“Thank you Hiryu,” Izuku said. He looked down sadly at his lost piece of fruit. “Were you really going to snitch on them to Nine?”

“No,” Hiryu admitted with a smug smirk. “But it got them to run off didn’t it?”

Izuku was smiling fully now. “You’re the best.”

“Don’t mention it,” Hiryu laughed. He bent down and ruffled Izuku’s hair with a concerned stare. “You know, they will keep picking on you unless you fight back. You’re supposed to be mean to people who are mean towards you. Twist Sen’s left wrist counterclockwise next time. He fractured his radius last summer and it never healed properly.”

Izuku nodded. “I will try to be mean next time.”

“That’s what I like to hear.” Hiryu’s eyes caught the banana on the ground. It was swarmed with tiny red ants now. “Are you still hungry?” Izuku nodded, opting against speaking in shame of his lisp. “Okay. Let’s go get some food then get that nose of yours checked out. It doesn’t look like it’s been properly reset at all.”

Hiryu held out his hand for Izuku and Izuku eagerly took it.

In the background, Tomura could be seen shaking his head and returning back to reading. The disgust in his face made shame twist and pull inside of Izuku. He knew it was because his brother agreed with Sen and Himiko. Tomura cared for him, but Tomura thought he was weak.

Izuku decided he would only miss Hiryu when he left with Kacchan.

ᔓᔓᔓ

The rest of the day blew by as usual. They returned to the classrooms at 13:00 and continued on with their language lessons. They wrapped the day up with a physical lesson where they practiced balance and form for fighting. Once Mr. Compress gave everyone a nod of approval with their stances, they were free to go at 17:00.

Big Brothers and Sisters were waiting outside their respective classrooms for their Littles. This was the time that they would train with their Littles or give them extra lessons. Sometimes they would eat together.

Tomura wasn’t into doing much with him during this time.

They ate quietly and then went back to their room. Tomura gave him an unpleasant scowl and rolled his eyes once the door was shut.

“Hiryu won’t always be there to save you,” Tomura pointed out while not looking at him. “He needs to stop fucking babying you. It’s an act of violence to shelter you like that knowing softness is punishable.”

Had this been a year ago, Izuku would’ve been hurt by Tomura’s words. But right now, the sting of them went in one ear and out the other because in one day, he’d be on a train with Kacchan.

Izuku nodded to cover up how he wasn’t listening and stiffly took a seat at his desk. He pulled out his Mandarin textbook and began quietly practicing the characters.

“I’m going down to the training facilities,” Tomura announced. He changed swiftly into his training gear that was dark green sweats with a white snake on the back of the shirt. “Do you want to come?”

“No. I need to work on my pronunciation.”

Tomura nodded, agreeing. “Good choice. Okay. I’ll be back at 23:00 for the nightly check in with Ms. Nagant. Keep studying and try to work on your stuttering too. It’s getting annoying.”

Izuku nodded again.

Tomura left out like he always did and never looked back. Which filled Izuku with giddy excitement. He sprung up from his chair and looked down at his little yellow watch.

It was 17:40. Perfect.

Izuku smiled with his crooked teeth and quickly rushed to grab his coat and boots. He put them in his backpack so he could be discreet.

Getting out was always trickier than getting in. He put his green backpack over his shoulders and opened the door for their room. He peaked around the hallway and saw some pairs of siblings talking and laughing with each other. Izuku blended in well, he kept his head down.

He took the elevator today. He admired the crystal buttons and the shimmery aesthetic of their home. Then he pressed the down button with his tiny finger. The glass doors opened for him and Izuku shuffled inside. He glanced over his shoulder and from up here he could see all the various floors of people bustling about.

He never really knew what happened on the other floors with the other siblings, but the view as he was lowered down was always amazing to him.

An indoor garden was at the lobby level, and people with folders were shuffling in and out. From his top view they started off looking like little ants until they morphed into recognizable people once he got to the lower levels.

Once the shiny doors dinged open, Izuku shuffled out in the crowd. No one paid him any mind for some reason. Izuku thought maybe they potentially assumed he was on his way to train with a Big Brother or Sister. The caretakers walked around in their white suits and dresses with clipboards. Their eyes were always glued to their papers scribbling marks with their green pens.

Izuku supposed they thought they had nothing to worry about. There was only one entrance that everyone knew. Those same doors were the only exit. As far as any caretaker knew, no one was ever able to get in or out with their knowledge.

When Izuku passed through the lobby, he stared at the one set of doors. They were stationed at the top of the triangle shape. Tall, shiny and opaque.

On either side of the doors were large, golden statues of snakes. Their eyes were emeralds and Izuku could have sworn those gems were boring into their souls. Next to these statues were four guards in green suits with rifles in their hands. Their eyes were always distant and glazed over as they watched the doors.

Izuku walked to the other side of the building with his head down and then slipped into the stairwell discreetly.

He walked down to the remaining levels to a part of their home that was always off limits.

The basement was similar to upstairs only it was darker and there were no kids. Eerie sounds arose like ghosts down here and sometimes Izuku swore he heard begging—but he never saw any faces.

He crept quietly to the backroom, heart racing in anticipation of seeing his best friend.

Then Izuku's breath caught when he heard footsteps shuffling his way.

He froze immediately. He wildly darted his eyes around and spotted a small crate next to him. Izuku ducked rapidly behind the large object and scooted all the way into the corner filled with shadows.

The footsteps gradually grew louder and as did the voices.

"What do you want us to do with the defective boy?" The voice of a man asked.

"What was his name again?"

Izuku's nerve endings lit on fire—he knew that voice. It was Nine.

"Mirio. The thirteen year old with blue eyes, blond hair and large build."

"Ah. 111." Nine sounded deeply agitated. "He's still in good physical shape, I'm sure he'll make use elsewhere. Ship him to Moore for money. We have no use for the ones who have trouble pulling the trigger. But how was his empathy level not caught sooner?"

"It seems like he was masking his emotions well," the second voice explained.

"Tell the caretakers to double the intensity training next week," Nine said. "I don't want another repeat of this. He's the second Phase Two Viper to act out. The last thing we need is for this to work its way up to One."

"Yes, sir."

The footsteps and voices grew further and quieter.

Izuku peaked from the side of the crate. His heart was pounding at an insane speed because Nine was not someone *any* of them wanted to come across. While Ms. Nagant was never nice, Nine was worse. Nine was cold beyond Izuku's understanding.

Izuku hurried quicker to the back room now. He pulled open the black door and crept inside. It was a useless room no one ever came inside of for all he knew, but it was used to store clothes for them in case anyone needed an extra pair. He often borrowed from it, giving all he could to Kacchan without anyone noticing.

Eagerly, Izuku pulled out his winter gear.

He pulled the plush hat over his ears and zipped up his coat all the way to his chin. He placed his school shoes inside of the backpack and neatly tucked it away behind one of the many shelves.

The final touch was one Izuku loved the most.

He opened his pencil case and pulled out the string ring he always wore around Kacchan. Izuku nervously pushed it on the finger that Kacchan taught him to and grinned wide.

With a big huff, Izuku dug his fingers into the ground. He precisely tipped the tile on one end to up end the other and quietly shoved it to the side. He smiled as he lowered himself into the dark underground.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku pulled his hat down further on his ears when the winter winds blew. He happily ignored it though and made his way dutifully towards Kacchan. When he arrived at the plaza, the sounds of familiar violin music greeted him.

However, when he got closer his pace slowed down.

Kacchan wasn't on the bench like he normally was.

Izuku's stomach tightened.

He walked up towards the violinist and glanced around the barren plaza. There was no one else besides him, the violinist and the forgotten statue of the angel that was weeping. The elder man smiled at him through his shivering.

"Hey there, little one!" The old man greeted him with his crooked smile. "How are you this fine winter evening?"

"I'm 'kay," Izuku mumbled, distracted. He was still searching around for blond hair and red eyes. "D-Did Kacchan come see you today?"

The violinist stopped playing.

Now his brown eyes were slightly concerned, like Hiryu's were sometimes. The elder man scratched his forehead and looked around and then offered Izuku an apologetic stare. This was the first time Izuku had seen him not blissfully happy.

"No. Sorry, little one. I thought he would come with you."

Izuku bit his lip to hold back the tears.

He looked down at his watch. It was 18:00.

“Kacchan!” Izuku called out loudly as he stumbled into the abandoned church.

The glimmering lights from the stainless glass windows filled the space as he repeated the nickname over and over again. Any other time Izuku would have marveled at how painterly the scene was, but right now he didn’t. He was frantically searching for blond hair and red eyes.

“Kacchan! ‘m sorry! Please come out! I didn’t mean to be late!”

Izuku sobbed to himself when he saw the nook was empty again. All of Kacchan’s things were still here exactly like they were yesterday. Suddenly, it didn’t seem like his best friend was simply walking around.

Was Kacchan safe?

Izuku had no idea as he stared around through his bleary eyes. He searched the church up and down, thinking maybe this was an extreme game of hide and seek. Sometimes they played catch the Kacchan—maybe this was like that? Yeah. It had to be a game. Izuku told this to himself, it was a game to find the Kacchan.

His vision was full of tears as he tried his best not to have a meltdown. He walked around Tokyo looking for blond hair and red eyes. Every time he saw someone similar to Kacchan he snapped his neck to see, only to find out he was mistaken. He searched until he was nearly out of time and finally sat down on the snow-covered bench in front of the violinist.

Izuku cried into his gloves.

“Do you want to try playing my violin, little one?” The elder man asked quietly.

Izuku lifted his head to see the man smiling sadly at him.

He nodded slowly as he stared at the pretty instrument. “You really would let me?”

“Of course! I used to be an amazing instructor in my other lifetime. I am multi-talented!”

The violinist put on a goofy act, clearing his throat and introducing himself as if he was in front of a grand ball. It made Izuku laugh through his crying and cheered him up enough to ease his sadness. Izuku watched intensely as the man began instructing and breaking down how to play the delicate instrument.

Then like a daydream, the elder man handed the violin over to Izuku.

Izuku took his gloves off and held the violin closely. Warmth ignited in him and lit up his tiny heart as he smiled sadly.

“Thank you,” Izuku whispered. “This is so nice of you.”

“Not a problem at all, little one,” the elder man smiled. He then helped Izuku poise correctly and helped the placement of his chin on the violin. “First lesson starts today.”

Izuku lost himself to his very first violin lesson.

He never thought of what it would be like to learn something that wasn’t human anatomy, or the entire geography of Japan. He stared at his hands in amazement that they could do something besides shoot a gun and throw knives at targets. Then gradually, he smiled when the image of Kacchan appeared in his mind as he started poorly playing the violin.

He closed his eyes and saw them dancing in the clouds together.

Then Izuku opened his eyes and caught a glimpse of the wedding band on the violinist’s finger. His sullen eyes glanced down to the string ring on his tiny finger as he played. He played harder as he gripped on tightly to the hope it represented.

We’re married. It’s okay. Kacchan said that they wouldn’t be separated again. They were going to board that train together and start a new life.

Izuku told this to himself the rest of the night to keep himself from crying.

Then he told this to himself the next day.

And the following.

And the next day after that.

He told himself this every day following and soon winter bled into one continuous snowstorm of loneliness. Young Izuku found himself practicing the violin every night in hopes that the song would bring the other boy back to him. But no one ever came. It was only him and the old man who always taught him something new every evening.

But Izuku waited and played no matter what.

Because he needed Kacchan and Kacchan needed him.

ᔓᔓᔓ

11 years before the incident

It was winter again and Izuku was nine now. He knew that because Ms. Nagant told him he needed to stop crying so much for his age after Mr. Compress hit him for scoring low on the knife throwing exam. It was unbecoming.

Izuku was nine now. He knew that because often he heard Tomura and Hiryu harshly discussing what was going to become of him at the age of ten—which was only a year away. Tomura had locked him in their room when he said he was sick of looking at him after he saved a butterfly.

Izuku was nine now. He knew that because it had been exactly a year since he last saw Kacchan.

Out of all three things proving his new age, only one hurt the most.

Izuku still went to the plaza every day through the secret passage no one knew about. He missed Kacchan so much some days it felt like his chest was caving in like one of those black holes they were taught about. The pain was threatening to consume him from the inside out if nothing was done. But nothing *could* be done because Kacchan was nowhere to be found.

In his endless search for blond hair and red eyes, Izuku always made sure to return in time for Ms. Nagant's nightly check in and feedback.

Her cold eyes were hardening with each passing day, and it seemed like she was meaner now. If she caught someone crying, she sent them to an isolation room. If she found out someone received low marks, they were given several licks with a long switch and were forced to say the equations correctly. Worst of all if she heard anyone stutter she made them squat until she was satisfied.

Something had shifted in all of them.

The Big Brothers and Sisters were more serious now. Forcefully training their Littles in combat style techniques. Most students went to their rooms limping with bruises. Many nights Izuku sat in cold ice in his bathroom across the way from Tomura's.

The caretakers were stricter. It didn't take a genius to figure out if the caretakers looked at you while ticking something on their clipboard, it was bad. Especially bad if someone was caught having an outburst of crying too much. The students were immediately dragged off somewhere by the large security guards in all green. Sometimes they returned. Sometimes they didn't.

This was enough to make everyone weary of having an outburst or showing weakness in front of the caretakers.

It came to a point where fear was strangling them. Or only some of them.

Many were thriving such as Himiko, Sen, and Tomura.

The division was clear who sought pleasure in this. The ones who were the cruelest were awarded in front of everyone to see, which inspired more cruelty like a vicious cycle no one could truly escape.

Izuku was one of the few who didn't want to aspire to such meanness because he was still dead set on getting on that train and never coming back.

He was still holding onto his wish that Kacchan would come back to him.

Izuku could feel something inside of him hurting though. He wondered if it came with being older or if it came with the pain of not seeing blond hair and kind red eyes. Whatever it was, it hurt—and it felt like a part of him was breaking.

The seasons had fully cycled but in Izuku's heart it remained winter the entire time Kacchan was missing. He started wondering if maybe Kacchan left on purpose—maybe Izuku was too tiny and weak for anyone to like him.

His own siblings hated him so why would someone as wonderful as Kacchan love him?

But a small voice in the back of his head was whispering something else. Something far worse than losing the affection of the best person in the world. His other theory was that Kacchan could've been dead somewhere, eyes rolled in the back of his head and body half frozen in the city streets.

But Izuku hoped that would never be true.

He wished every night on all the stars he could find that Kacchan only stopped loving him and was not dead.

ᗰᗰᗰ

On a particular night, Izuku walked back to his home in the neon-lit city. He had spent the evening with the violinist learning a new chord but for an unspoken reason the music reminded him of Kacchan. It was strong, loud, and explosive even. Everything he loved about Kacchan.

Deep in his thoughts, Izuku casually passed by a bookstore. The loud sound of fake gunshots reached his ears and made his head turn out of instinct.

His crying slowed up as he stared at a scene that confused him.

He strolled up slowly to the large window in the crowd. As people passed him by, Izuku stayed glued to his spot. There, he saw on the small television screen a tall, blond man with blazing red eyes. *Like Kacchan.* The man's hair was straight as a pin and flowing with the breeze as he stood proudly holding a rose out in his hand. He was giving it to a woman in front of him who was beautiful beyond belief with chocolate brown hair and honey-colored eyes.

Young Izuku tilted his head when he noticed their wedding bands.

The woman on the screen splayed her arm across her head, swooned and fell into the man's arms, easily caught. Izuku stared on, as they kissed and then a subtle pink blush arose on his cheeks when he realized what was happening.

This is romance like Kacchan showed me Izuku thought to himself.

He started twisting his fingers together, feeling a tightness of want in his chest.

However, the longer he stared the more he fixated on the man's features.

Blond hair and red eyes.

Izuku smiled a bit to himself because he wondered if Kacchan would look like this when they were adults. He stepped closer and decided maybe not *exactly* like this man. Kacchan had sharper eyes. And he only smiled on special occasions. Kacchan also always did a thing with his face where he grinned with a lopsided confidence and his eyes were always full of fire as he talked.

Izuku watched the whole video as it played out dramatic, exciting scenes. One scene was of the man, shirtless, lost in the desert, searching for his love. Another scene was of the woman fighting off several guards and successfully escaping. Then all the tiny kisses and romantic moments between the two. Izuku softly giggled and blushed whenever it showed something romantic on the screen—then at the end it showed a terrible cliffhanger that caused Izuku to gasp.

He pressed his hands against the glass window, confused. *Where's the rest?*

"Want to continue the romantic adventures of Saishū kōkyōkyoku?" The disembodied voice on screen asked. Izuku nodded eagerly. "Then come buy the book here to join our hero and heroine and their epic, romantic adventure!"

The screen showed a book in glittering, lavender light.

Izuku's eyes sparkled.

He stared at the man with blond hair and red eyes once more before marching into the bookstore.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku crept into their room quietly that night with the book safely tucked in his backpack. The bookstore owner told him he was too young for it, but Izuku quietly stuck it in his bag when no one was looking and darted.

When he arrived in his room, per usual, he arrived before Tomura. His big brother always trained late, making sure his fighting skills were in top shape.

Izuku rolled back the black rug by his bed, exposing the wooden floorboards underneath. He carefully used his knife to unhinge one of the planks. He loosened it until he could tip it like the tile piece downstairs. He checked the size of it and smiled when his new book fit perfectly inside.

After Tomura came back and Ms. Nagant did her nightly assessment of them, Izuku waited until it was the deep hours of the night to slowly sink to the floor. He reached into the floorboard and grabbed his book and opened it up to the first page.

Immediately, the man with blond hair and red eyes appeared in his head.

Then gradually as he read, the image filled out to an older version of Kacchan. Izuku smiled, envisioning Kacchan as he read. He could perfectly see this as him and Kacchan holding hands and running away together like the couple in the book.

As he read for an hour, it became clear to Izuku he could get in a lot of trouble if this book was found.

Their caretakers made it a point to tell them they were only allowed to read from literature they selected. All of the books they could check out in their home's library centered around cruelty or exposed the crimes of mankind. It was stories that reinforced how horrible the outside world was.

But *this* book—this book gave Izuku some layer of hope that the outside world wasn't that terrible.

Romance seemed so nice.

Hand holding. Smiling. Caring for each other. All these things Izuku was punished for at home, but in this book the characters were free to be nice without consequences. It reminded Izuku of all the warmness Kacchan always gave him. Kacchan was the first person to show him people could be kind and not everyone was terrible and mean. He introduced romance to him, and for that, Izuku was more than thankful.

To keep the sadness at bay, Izuku read for an hour in the dark every night from that book. He didn't know what some of these strange words meant like 'cherish' or 'endearment' or 'devotion'. Whenever he tried to locate them in their Viper Academy dictionary, they were nowhere to be found. Other normal words he knew were there such as 'antagonize' and 'revolt' along with 'loathe'.

Izuku didn't even understand what some of these characters were doing. These types of actions were foreign to him, and he had never heard of some of the stuff they were doing. However, there were some phrases he knew in this book thanks to Kacchan.

Kissing. Marriage. I love you.

Izuku smiled at the very few parts he could understand. He decided to read those ones over and over.

"I love you, Kacchan," Izuku whispered in the dark as he read the confessions on the page. He wet his lips out of nerves and tasted the words on his tongue. He quietly smiled with a blush saying the words out loud. "I. Love. You."

Izuku was giddy a bit, suddenly full of hope that he could practice saying 'I love you' for when Kacchan finally came back to him.

ᔓᔓᔓ

The months passed on and Izuku was once again quietly sneaking out. How many times had he done this? He had no real clue anymore.

He wandered through the vast underground of Tokyo, admiring it as he went with images of romantic adventures in his head. He grazed his hand along the surface of the gigantic pillar,

appreciating how sturdy it was. He giggled as he thought about showing Kacchan this underground and maybe they could act out scenes from that book together.

"This way, Izuku!" The voice of Kacchan said in his head. He could perfectly envision the bigger boy proudly leading the way with his beaming grin. *"I'll protect you! We can make it to Okinawa this way!"* Izuku smiled sadly at the daydream in his head.

He hummed a bit, walking around the corner to find his exit.

Then Izuku's heart dropped all the way into the cold ground.

Standing there stationed by the exit tunnel was Tomura. His arms were crossed, and an ugly scowl was pulling down on his face. Izuku's mouth gaped, and his eyes stretched wide. His limbs began shaking as he stepped backwards in disbelief.

How did he—

Then his brother's deadly eyes cut up to him.

The first instinct Izuku had was to run.

He bolted in the opposite direction and immediately Tomura chased after him. Izuku's breathing labored as he pushed his body further and further as fast as he could. He skidded, nearly toppling over when he switched directions in hopes of losing Tomura.

But his brother was quicker. Older. Better trained. He tackled Izuku to the rough, concrete ground in an instant.

The skin on Izuku's face shallowly tore open from the uneven surface grinding against his cheek as they collided. Izuku screamed loudly, and Tomura grunted in frustration. Izuku was roughly turned over and slammed on his back. His whole world spun in dizzying circles as his brother fisted the collar of his uniform and pinned him down to the ground.

Izuku tried to open his mouth to yell for Tomura to let him go but he was brutally backhanded before any words could come out.

"Are you out of your mind?!" Tomura screamed. His voice bounced all around the empty space, sounding as frightening as rolling thunder. "How long, Izuku?! How *fucking* long have you been sneaking out?!"

Izuku coughed violently. His mouth filled up with the taste of iron as his lip split open. He tried to cry, but Tomura gave him no room to do so. Strong fingers dug into his jaw and forced his mouth open.

"No goddamn crying. I'm sick of your pathetic ass crying! You better speak right *now*," Tomura demanded.

"T-Two years," Izuku gasped.

Instantly, his brother's grip on his jaw went entirely slack and Izuku lobbed his head to the side, sobbing.

Tomura sat up and stared at him in horrifying shock.

"So all those days you said you were studying…" Tomura trailed off. "…This is why you're so far behind in everything." He ran a shaky hand through his hair. "This is why you're so weak."

Izuku hung his head away in shame. "I'm sorry."

His brother pulled at his silver hair and groaned out loud. His eyes stared wide at the ground unfocused. Panic was eroding all over Tomura's features as he glanced around frantically.

"…This is my fault, isn't it?" Tomura whispered wearily.

Izuku kept his tongue still. He knew Tomura wasn't asking him.

"I should've kept a closer eye on you." Tomura punched the ground next to Izuku's head with a frustrated grunt. Izuku flinched and screwed his eyes shut. "Jin never lets Sen out of his sight. I should've forced you to come with me every day to the training facilities. All this time, I actually thought you were too soft and scared to leave our room. But you've been tricking me. You're a *liar*."

Then Tomura frowned and refocused his gaze on Izuku.

"And where *have* you been going, Izuku?"

Izuku thought of Kacchan and his heart stopped. His mind searched for any other reason and was quickly drawing a blank. "I-I…"

"Tell the truth. You can lie to anyone else but never lie to me again, Izuku."

Izuku's jaw trembled. "I…I found a funny man on the street who plays violin. I thought his music was pretty…I've been going to listen to it every day."

It was partially true.

The first time he met Kacchan, he was listening to the violinist for the first time too. He had wandered around the streets of Tokyo in amazement at all the lights after emerging from the underground. But Izuku's ear caught on the sound of a beautiful song and walked towards it like he was in a trance. He sat down on the old bench, captivated by the way the man was playing the violin.

Shortly after, the world brought him Kacchan.

"Mediocre violin music?" Tomura sneered. "That's what you've been risking your life over?"

"I figured if I was caught I would get a couple of hits, but it wouldn't be a big deal."

“Leaving is the biggest strike anyone could get. It results in death.”

Tomura rolled off of him and roughly yanked Izuku up from the cold ground. He grasped his shoulder harshly and pulled him in towards him until they were mere inches away.

“Listen to me, and listen to me carefully,” Tomura hissed. “Recently, I learned how well our goddamn Littles do is a mark of assessment for Big Brothers and Sisters. So don’t be *selfish*. When I am cruel to you, I am cruel for the sake of our future. I need you. You never step foot outside of our home again or we will both end up *dead*.”

Izuku’s thoughts stopped when something didn’t click together.

“Dead?” Izuku questioned in a whisper.

Tomura’s expression grew colder. “Dead.”

“W-Why dead? Who would kill us?”

“I’m not supposed to say,” Tomura admitted, his eyes averted down at the ground. Izuku’s stomach dropped further because that was a yes to his question. Someone was going to not only hurt them but kill them if he left. “It’s part of protocol we don’t tell you until the moment is right, and if it's found out I did—I can be killed. There’s more at stake here than grades and assessments.”

Izuku thought about all the punishments he endured already. “Why would they kill us for something so small?”

“Nothing we do is *small*. Our actions carry a heavier weight than all of us.”

Izuku wrung his hands as his tiny heart banged loudly.

The tears pushing against his eyes were for too many reasons for him to count. If he had boarded that train with Kacchan, Tomura would have been *killed*. How could he be so reckless?

Maybe he was stupid like Tomura always said.

There’s so much I don’t know—

“Izuku, I care about you, even if I cannot properly show it,” Tomura muttered suddenly. He looked down at his hands sadly as if disappointed in them. “When you turn ten, things are going to drastically change for everyone. When the last person ages—you’re going to go somewhere that will test your abilities and only some of you will make it back.”

“T-The Cull?” Izuku whispered. “But that’s a nice event.”

“The Cull is not nice.” Tomura’s frown turned sour. “After that you will learn the world out there is *awful*. Everything we were taught about it was true and it will be in your face. There’s nothing but horrible, evil people polluting this planet. You never want to be a part of

the shitty world out there. Everyone is always lying, judging each other like hypocrites, or bullying. It's all so *pointless*."

Izuku made a face and rubbed his wrists. "Himiko and Sen do all of that already. They are just as bad as the people out there."

"*Exactly*." Tomura exclaimed harshly. "But they are at least tied to you. They have to be considerate to an extent. The people out there have no alliance towards you—Himiko and Sen however *do*. But more importantly, I do. I…I have come to realize in our life circumstances that there's only us."

Izuku recoiled back, confused. "Us?"

"Me and you," Tomura clarified.

His brother motioned between them and then gingerly squatted down to Izuku's height. The gesture took Izuku by surprise, this was the first act of softness his brother had ever given him. Izuku liked it a bit more than he thought he would as he finally looked Tomura eye to eye and not gazing up at him terrified.

Tomura cupped his face and Izuku almost cried from the touch.

"No one else besides us will ever be fully trustworthy," Tomura said in a low voice. "But that's why you *need* to listen to me, Izuku. I am the only person who will ever have your best interest at heart. I may hurt you, but I would *never* kill you. So, please do as I say. Do you understand?"

"Yes," Izuku whispered, terrified at what had been revealed. "I understand, Tomura."

Tomura nodded, happy with the response. "Good. Now let's get home before we get killed."

He stood up to full height and held out his hand for Izuku to take. But Izuku didn't right away, feeling all sorts of things inside of him he couldn't decode.

He kept imagining someone killing them. Nagant or Nine would be good guesses—he could believe that. Sen and Himiko too. And if people were as horrible as Mr. Compress made them out to be, then who was left besides Tomura?

However, Izuku's mind wandered to Kacchan and the violinist. He furrowed his brow—conflicted.

"C-Can I go out one more time?" Izuku dared to ask.

Tomura's face dropped, and a deadly leer spilled into his features. "You're not serious are you?"

"One more. I-I won't be long. Please let me go one more time."

"And *why* should I do that?"

“I-I want to say goodbye to the violin man,” Izuku muttered, oddly ashamed. “I promise. Nothing more.”

Izuku stared down at his red boots so that Tomura wouldn’t see he was lying.

“Fine.” Tomura huffed. “Let this prove how *patient* I am with you, Izuku. No one else would be this kind after you nearly got them killed. Every second we’re down here is putting our lives in danger. I hope you realize that.”

“Th-Thank you,” Izuku whispered. He bowed lightly and waited for his cue.

Tomura waved his hand and rolled his eyes. He took a seat on the ground and looked up at the high tunnel ceiling. Izuku rushed out one more thank you before taking off to the direction of the plaza.

ɯɯɯ

When Izuku arrived, he was weeping as much as the statue of the angel.

He looked up at her eyes, and for once finally understood the type of sorrow that was captured in her face. The cracks that spread all over the statue’s body felt the same as the splintering pain that rippled through him. This was going to be the last time.

Izuku looked down sadly at his little yellow watch.

He waited, one last time. The violinist played The Dance of The Love Birds, one last time.

Izuku quietly cried the entire performance, and the violinist didn’t utter a word. When the time drew near for Izuku to leave, the violinist walked over and sat on the bench next to Izuku. He put the violin down in his lap and stared at it. He turned to Izuku with a solemn gaze.

“You’re sadder than usual, little one. Did something happen?”

“Is…Is the world really that bad?” Izuku asked, confused and afraid. He tried to wipe away his tears before they froze. “Y-You seem so nice. I don’t understand what’s real or not.”

The violinist of course scrunched his face. “Whatever do you mean?”

“My big brother and caretakers tell me everyone in the world is corrupted and horrible,” Izuku explained. “That everyone is evil or would think our family are monsters, so no one is worth our time. B-But I really liked spending time with you. I *loved* spending time with Kacchan—and you two weren’t bad. I-I don’t understand what’s true or not.”

The violinist didn’t say a word.

He leaned back on the bench and stared up at the statue. Then like a rising sun, he smiled gradually and warmly.

“The world is cruel,” the violinist answered in the clearest voice Izuku ever heard. His brown eyes were shiny with tears from his memories as he studied the snow-covered angel. “Your family is right. The world is judgmental and can strip away at the tiniest piece of kindness it sees. Devour it even. But that’s the beauty of life is that you can choose to stand in the face of all those sharp teeth and still choose to be kind.”

Izuku sniffled slightly, tears slowing. “A-And you’re kind, yes? You’re not bad.”

“Well, that all depends on who you ask.” A chuckle. “I have many people who would say I am selfish for throwing my life away and others who would say I am a terrible person. B-But one person would say I am perfect.” He lifted his wrinkled, veiny hand to show his silver band and smiled distantly. “As long as there is one person who thinks you are good, that is all that you need. That’s why I think you and your friend Kacchan are fated.”

Izuku stared at the glimmering silver on the man’s pale finger.

He twisted his string ring through his glove with a sad hint of hope. “You really think so?”

“I *know* so,” the violinist chuckled. He grinned wide with all his teeth and clapped his hands. “I-I never told you this little one, but The Dance of The Love Birds song—I had been too heartbroken to ever play it again after my life fell apart. But then I played it for the first time in years and both of you came and helped me perfect it! If that’s not fate I don’t know what is.”

Izuku’s eyes watered again. “Th-That’s a good point.”

“Exactly! You’ll find each other again. Fate works funnily because I never could have perfected my music without either of you. The universe gave me enough hope to play my song that day and you two both wandered into my sad life.”

“Your life s’not sad, sir,” Izuku whispered.

The violinist only smiled at him.

Izuku felt pain in his chest as he looked down at his watch again. The minute number switched and with it brought a heavy reminder that his time was spreading thin. Izuku took off his backpack and swung it around. His limb felt as heavy as his heart as he reached down inside of it to pull out a clear plastic bag of disorganized yen.

He thrusted it to the elder man.

The man nearly dropped his whole violin to the ground and scrambled to catch it.

“Wh-What is this?” The violinist questioned. His eyes bugged wide, and his throat caught. “Little one, where did you get this much money and why are you carrying it around? That’s dangerous.”

“I-I was saving it for me and Kacchan to start a life in Okinawa,” Izuku whispered. “I’ve been taking a couple of yen every day from a room no one pays attention to in my home.

There's a lot of money in there, and they never noticed the handful of bills I take when I pick the lock."

Izuku nudged the bag closer to the man, but now all the initial surprise was gone.

The violinist didn't take the money. "…Then why are you giving it to me if it's for your new life?"

"Because Kacchan s'*gone*." Izuku's voice broke, and his face distorted in pain.

His throat swelled; it hurt to even speak the words out loud—as if every stutter and syllable he could barely pronounce was clawing its way up and out of his throbbing throat. Izuku cried until the pain alleviated and the elder man didn't interrupt him as he grieved.

"He's gone," Izuku nearly hissed as he wept. "And this is the last time I'm allowed to go outside otherwise something bad will happen to me and my brother." Izuku lolled his head down and let his tears hit the snow. "All I want to do is wait for Kacchan to come back so we can be happy—but I *can't*. I ca-can't wait. Pl-Please take the money. You can use it to buy a new violin and keep playing pretty songs."

A lot more forcefully, Izuku thrusted the money into the elder man's hands.

This time the violinist took it. He wrapped his fingers around the rotund bag but didn't smile. He carefully tucked it inside of his satchel and then picked up his violin.

"Here," the violinist whispered. He pushed the ivory instrument into Izuku's empty hands. "In exchange for the money, you take my violin."

Izuku's crying slowly eased up in confusion.

"Wh-Why are you giving me this? This is your favorite thing, sir. You told us your wife made this for you."

The violinist nodded. "She did. She was a woodworker, and this was her finest piece of work. Which is why I think you should have it. This way you can remember how much fun we had together these past two years, and you can always remember your Kacchan until he comes back to you."

Izuku wished that would be true, but his hope was wearing thin.

The elder man saw his downtrodden stare. He shifted and picked up the old violin from the bench. He slowly shuffled over to his messy belongings and dug out his violin case that had a few spare dollars inside. He neatly packed up the violin for Izuku on top of the change, and clicked it shut.

With his trembling hands, he placed the item in Izuku's lap before speaking words that stuck with Izuku for a lifetime.

"Nothing lasts forever, but memories sometimes do."

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku wandered back to the abandoned church after his goodbyes with the violinist. The entire walk, he hugged the giant case of the violin as if it was Kacchan. He lobbed his head on it as he dragged his feet, using the case to support his head as he wandered to the tilting building.

He crawled in the usual way and stopped in the center of the isle. He looked up with his bloodshot eyes to the beautiful stained-glass image in front of him. He never had taken the time to study it before. His eyes were always on Kacchan, but now without the other boy he sadly appreciated the beauty of the snake and apple in the window. The glittering specks of green, red, purple and blue reflected everywhere and across his face as he stared up sadly at it.

Izuku did one last walk around.

Usually, Izuku never saw how tattered this place was because it was where his happiest memories happened. No more laughter meant he could see the cobwebs and the rotting wood. He could see the mildew and the way the ceiling had several holes. He could see how neglected it was.

With a heavy heart, young Izuku checked the shower downstairs.

He checked underneath all the benches.

He checked the upstairs attic and around the back.

He searched everywhere for Kacchan one last time, and he couldn't find any trace of the other boy. All Izuku was left with was their unfulfilled dreams and the new ache inside of his chest to accompany their sweet memories.

His mind stayed blank as he wandered in the nook and sat down. He brushed off a tiny speck of dust from the shelf out of habit. He had kept it clean for Kacchan in case he ever wanted to come back to him. But he supposed he no longer had to keep it clean or safe for Kacchan because Kacchan wasn't here anymore. Izuku glanced up at the All Might poster through his tears.

"He said we would always come back to each other," Izuku whispered, disappointed. "Why hasn't he come back?"

He had no more energy to let his sadness wreck its way out of him. Instead, he curled his fist bitterly and leaned his head against the back wall of the nook. He cried until his eyes were sore whenever he blinked, and his heart felt like nothing but a void.

He looked down at his little yellow watch and saw the time.

22:22.

Izuku's time was up.

Izuku shifted upright in the nook and reached in his backpack. He pulled out a small piece of paper and a pencil and wrote the one thing he had been waiting to say to Kacchan, in case he never made his way back to him. Because that's what he had said—they would always find a way back to each other.

I love you, Kacchan. Please come back.

Maybe if Kacchan saw this, then he would finally return. One way or another.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku crawled back down into the underground, feeling incomplete. He knew he had left a piece of him behind with that note. He looked sadly at the violin case wondering how his brother would react to him even having this.

When he was expecting the worst, he was a little stunned to find Tomura standing up looking around at the tall underground tunnel. There was a curious glint in his eyes that Izuku had never seen—it was close to inspiration. His brother ran his hand along one of the pillars in marvel.

"Is this connected to the flood system?" Tomura questioned, ignoring the violin case Izuku was towing.

"Uh, no," Izuku whispered. "It was abandoned during construction when the city decided to go for a different design. It's entirely vacant."

Tomura hummed, as if impressed. He put his hands into his uniform pockets and nodded around. His deep red eyes then turned to Izuku and caught sight of the violin. There was a split-second look of disapproval, but ultimately tiredness won.

"Let me guess, he gave you the violin as a goodbye gift," Tomura said flatly.

Izuku nodded, embarrassed. He gripped onto it tightly, expecting his brother to snatch it out of his arms and smash it to pieces. But Tomura didn't say or do anything.

"You can keep it," Tomura said without any emotion in his voice. "Make sure to hide it well from Ms. Nagant at night."

Izuku perked up, surprised. "Really? You're letting me keep it?"

His brother put his hand on his nape, causing Izuku to flinch. "I am. On one condition."

"Wh-What is that?"

"From this day on, you're going to dedicate your time to training seriously." Tomura's fingers dug into his nape as if he was trying to rip out the kindness directly from his skin. "No more softness from here on out."

Izuku's heart hurt a bit. He thought about Kacchan and the violinist who had brought so much light to his tiny life. Then he hung his head when he realized that he needed to do as Tomura said if he wanted to stay alive and safe.

"Okay. I understand," Izuku whispered.

Over the next few months, Izuku's mind and body were pushed to their limits. Tomura didn't ease up on him one bit and forced him to train in their room sometimes. Izuku had many nights where he questioned if this was all worth it to be a part of this family, but at the end of the day he had nowhere else to go.

So, he trained. He bled. He struggled.

He did everything Tomura said because Tomura always reassured him that he knew what was best for him.

One day during dinner, Tomura switched their smoothies when no one was looking.

"Drink mine instead," Tomura whispered. "Trust me on this one."

Izuku was confused because he thought their drinks were all the same. However, whenever he drank Tomura's smoothie, later that night Izuku found himself puking and heaving over their toilet.

Tomura would rub his back while Izuku sobbed and clutched his stomach.

"I-It hurts," Izuku whined as he dropped his head. He never felt anything like this, it was like fangs were gnawing at him from the inside out. He gasped a bit and tried to steady his vision. "Wh-Why does it hurt so much? I don't want to drink your smoothie anymore."

"You'll thank me later," Tomura said tiredly. "We're upping your tolerance early."

"Tolerance to *what*?" Izuku groaned.

Tomura didn't answer him. He simply rubbed Izuku's back some more and patted him down with wet towels. Izuku tried to ask again but instead he unwillingly heaved, and he could have sworn he tasted blood in his mouth.

Eventually, drinking Tomura's smoothie didn't hurt. It only gave him a dull ache in his stomach, and he was questioning what exactly was in their smoothies after that.

He then started noticing that there were specific smoothies given to students depending on their age. Izuku found this strange, but he had no time to think about it as he tried his best to focus on training for The Cull. It seems like all the Big Sisters and Brothers were pushing their Littles harder.

Tomura wasn't alone in his strife.

After school in the training facilities, Izuku would glance around at the various pairings.

Particularly, he would stare at Sen and his big brother, Jin.

Jin was one of the eldest, around seventeen years old. He had a funny, goofy personality that was deceiving in a terrible way. It was as if there were two of him. Jin's smile was a double headed demon that evoked false kindness in one face only to have the other side of him devour the person while they were distracted by his smile. Izuku realized if Jin smiled at someone, he likely was going to harm them.

That was of course, unless they were Sen. Jin loved Sen, even Izuku could tell. Sen was his pride and joy, and they were inseparable.

Sen and Jin were nearly matched in hand and hand combat at this point.

Izuku gazed in fear and amazement when Sen perfectly took down Jin. The pair high-fived and Sen puffed his chest out proudly. Then his eyes cut to Izuku and his smile transformed into a vicious threat.

Sen dragged his thumb across his throat while locking eyes with Izuku.

"Izuku," Tomura hissed. He snapped his fingers, drawing Izuku's attention back to him. "Focus on me. Remember if you get too distracted by what's going on around you, you'll lessen your chance of winning a match in combat."

Izuku slumped his shoulders and glanced down. "I'm—I'm really far behind…aren't I? Sen is basically perfect."

"You are, but pay them no mind," Tomura muttered. "Sen is far from perfect. Jin is instilling arrogance into Sen and arrogance leads to cockiness, which is a *weakness*, not a strength. Now let's go again. We'll go down to the shooting range after this to sharpen your aim."

Izuku nodded, understanding what Tomura was saying.

He melted back into his fighting stance and furrowed his brow. Tomura struck first, making Izuku wince in pain as he barely had time to dodge. But he took every hit and kept on his feet the entire time. They went several more excruciating rounds like this, and Izuku kept his focus on Tomura and only Tomura.

Part of him wished his brother would ease up, but mercy was not something Tomura knew.

10 years before incident

Over the next year, Izuku watched everyone in his life grow colder as they all aged to ten. Less and less emotion was allowed to be shown and many kids were willingly crueler to each

other. The Big Brothers and Big Sisters were shorter tempered, and their caretakers were somehow icier.

Their training sessions were significantly intense, leaving multiple students with broken bones and bruises. Izuku often left with black eyes whenever Tomura lost his temper and even Himiko cried herself into a meltdown. However, she only did this once.

It was soon implemented that students who were caught displaying negative traits such as crying, hesitation, or anything the caretakers deemed as weakness were taken away to the basement. The student would be locked away in the basement any time from one day to three.

When they returned, they seemed hollower, and they never cried again.

Izuku quickly learned how to mask his emotions because of this.

He had no clue what was in the basement, but if it was enough to rattle Himiko—then he had great fears about it. He found a way to focus his mind whenever he wanted to cry or break down. When he felt those emotions incoming, Izuku crawled to the part of his mind that was warm.

It was the side of his memory that held Kacchan.

He could perfectly envision blond hair and red eyes and feel the kisses his best friend used to lay on his cheek. Izuku would smile whenever he thought about this, and he didn't feel the urge to cry. Even while being punished in front of the class for his stutter, Izuku took every hit with the ruler from Mr. Compress without shedding a tear.

He filled his head with beautiful thoughts of blond hair, red eyes and romance the entire time to keep him tethered.

ᔓᔓᔓ

After his punishment from Mr. Compress, Izuku wandered into his room without a peep. He noted that Tomura was sitting there on the edge of his bed. His brother was blissfully zoned out, dressed in all black gear, weapons secured to his body and speckles of red were on his face.

Izuku stiffened at the sight of blood.

Blood meant a red folder from Ms. Nagant, more than likely.

She always gave Tomura a red folder once a week. When that red folder was seated in his palm, a flicker of interest would spark to life in Tomura's eyes. He would come back calmer, and more than likely have evidence of a fight taped to him.

"I heard you didn't cry while you got hit in front of the class today," Tomura said. He turned his face, revealing a splatter of red blood caked on his cheek. "Is that true?"

Izuku nodded, not moving from the doorway. “It’s true.”

Tomura hummed and rolled his shoulders. “Good boy. I’m impressed you went from sobbing to quiet so quickly.”

“Thank you,” Izuku muttered.

Tomura stood up and stalked over to his wardrobe. He dropped his dirtied ski mask into the hamper and Izuku noticed a couple of injuries on his arm, as if someone was swinging at him with a set of knives.

“What’s your trick?” Tomura asked as he unbuckled his chest holster.

“I…I focus on something that makes me calm,” Izuku confessed quietly. “It helps me a lot.”

“Interesting. I do the same.” Tomura turned on the safety on all his guns and neatly put them back in his trunk. “I guess we’re more alike than I thought.”

Izuku tilted his head at his brother, surprised that there was anything that could keep Tomura calm and collected.

“Really?” Izuku questioned. “What makes you calm?”

Tomura’s smile twisted with cruelty. He walked over to Izuku, and the sharp smell of iron breeched Izuku’s nose. He wanted to flinch but didn’t move as his brother leaned down to whisper into his ear.

“The thought of killing disgusting people,” Tomura confessed. “I imagine myself slitting all of their throats as I sit on a throne as dark as black sand.”

Izuku recoiled immediately. He was taken back by the answer, not expecting such a staggering response. He thought maybe it was a joke—However, when he caught sight of the rare smirk on his brother’s face he knew it was the truth.

Tomura wiped the blood off his face with the back of his hand. A smirk sat on his lips and bloodlust curled in his eyes.

Izuku studied Tomura, and he could see something there that wasn’t before. It was deep, and endless as though the last pieces of Tomura’s kindness had finally been plucked clean from his mind and left a large gap.

It was a hole as big as the city they lived in and Izuku wondered if this was how he would grow up to be like.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When the night before The Cull came, everyone seemed tense.

Tomura allowed a rest day for them the day before the event. He made sure to feed Izuku and they relaxed in their room going over tiny last-minute things. They both laid in the dark, quiet

enough that anything could be heard. Izuku didn't reach for his book that night, and there was no snoring from his brother, which meant he was awake.

"Tomura," Izuku whispered in the dark. "What does cull even mean?"

He had searched for it, but in all instances he couldn't find it in any Viper Dictionary dictionaries.

"Cull has two definitions," Tomura said. "The first means to select from a large group."

"…And the second?"

"To slaughter the weak from the group."

ᔓᔓᔓ

To slaughter.

Izuku repeated that to himself the next morning and suddenly everything Tomura had warned him about was clicking into place. He knew better than to ask what The Cull really was, it was a forbidden topic according to Tomura—but they had been raised to know it was exciting and fun.

However, Izuku didn't feel like that was true when the day came.

All Izuku could feel on his skin was a unique type of fear. It was stronger than the terror he felt when Himiko or Sen leered at him. Or the strange sense of warning whenever Ms. Nagant's eyes squinted at him. This fear was heavy like an expanding black ocean inside of him. It was growing bigger and bigger with every second that passed.

All the Littles said goodbye eagerly to their Bigs with tiny backpacks on them. Some hugged. Some didn't.

Izuku watched curiously as a Big sister, Ibara, didn't exactly hug her little all the way. There was something sad in Ibara's eyes, and she refused to meet any of their gazes. She swept her long green hair out of her face and turned away from them.

Izuku gazed around, sensing something was wrong.

Tomura squatted down to his height and snapped his fingers in his face.

"Izuku," Tomura whispered seriously. "Remember, survive. That's all you have to do."

"Survive," Izuku repeated slowly. "I only have to survive."

Tomura nodded in approval and ruffled his hair. "You're going to be fine."

Izuku bit the inside of his cheek. His brother never lied—but this felt like the first time he did.

They were escorted out of their home with many eyes from all the floors peering down at them. Izuku stared behind him at Tomura, who was staring after him. He seemed worried which worried Izuku even more. Izuku could feel a small push of tears against the back of his eyes as Tomura's figure grew smaller and smaller. He could barely indulge in how giddy everyone his age was.

Sen and Himiko were holding hands, skipping. Other kids were discussing how they were excited to finally be a part of the family. They walked through the front doors for the first time in their lives and everyone stared around in wonder.

Izuku had seen the outside before, so he didn't stare too hard like everyone else. But he did note how the area where they live looked so different from his window. He could see gruff people with scars on their eyes staring at them with sickened smiles.

"Another year, another mass sacrifice," one man whispered within earshot. A sharp string of chuckles from people nearby. "They produce those fuckers like they're machines nowadays."

Izuku turned his head slightly to see the man grinning at them with a cigarette hanging out of his mouth.

He did a two-finger salute to them as they were loaded onto a large, metallic gray bus.

ᔓᔓᔓ

The bus stopped and they were rounded up like cattle to get onto a large boat.

Izuku stayed silent the whole time while the other kids gasped in amazement. The boat was fancy with gold decorations inside with plush rooms and chandeliers all over.

Below deck, on the walls of the boats were oil painting portraits of people from their family tree they had studied. When everyone else was running around having fun, Izuku walked up and down the green carpeted hallway looking at the faces.

The first portrait was Nine. Izuku recognized him as the head father of their home.

The next were a sequence of several other people with marks labeled 1 through 10. They were all around Nine's age with stale emotionless expressions. These were the people who ran the other homes of their family. They were taught there were nine other homes around Japan and they were all watched over by the Divine Ten.

Sitting there with the biggest portrait of all was the Grand Father, One.

His curly hair was entirely silver like coins and the wrinkles on his face showed his age gracefully. His red eyes were about as empty as his heart, and he was staring down at the viewer as if he ruled over everyone. They were always taught to be thankful to One and the Divine Ten for allowing them to live a life full of purpose in their otherwise meaningless existence.

Izuku stared up at the portrait for a long time when he noticed something he hadn't before.

One had very faint freckles.

ᔓᔓᔓ

They arrived on an island with a large, all black building. It was an exact duplicate to their home from the outside.

This time, everyone was silent.

The original happiness that blanketed everyone faded slightly. Now, there was only confusion as they were shuffled around towards the building. Izuku swallowed slightly as they were brought inside.

Unlike their home, this place was empty and sterile. This was how Izuku imagined hospitals to be from what Mr. Compress would describe.

They were pointed to the side of a large room with a row of tiny cubicles and pale white lights. They waded in nothing as the caretakers left, and the next set of people to enter the room made everyone's mouth zip tightly.

Izuku's eyes widened a bit when he saw Nine walk in coolly with his hands behind his back. His long, silver hair was brushed into a low ponytail and his dark suit was spotless with his purple tie. Right above his heart was a symbol of twin vipers pinned.

"Welcome to The Cull," Nine announced in a forceful voice. Everyone's backs straightened. "I'll be overseeing your time here for the next few days along with Ms. Nagant, Mr. Compress, and a special guest. The Governor of Tokyo."

The three people in question strolled out next.

The Governor had a very distinctive face. Rosy cheeks, pointed nose and jet black hair. He smiled with his eyes just barely like he was hoarding secrets. His hands clasped together as he waved to them, and everyone waved back to him.

Right behind him, Ms. Nagant and Mr. Compress appeared. They looked entirely different. It was as if a switch was turned on inside of them and they didn't smile or wave to them.

"You all will be given a test," Ms. Nagant explained. She gestured to the cubicles next to them. "It's a simple examination. Please answer as if you were in those scenarios and when you are done, turn in your packet to either me or Mr. Compress."

"An exam?" Izuku could hear Himiko behind him whisper. "That's what the cull is? What has all that target practice been for then?" She sounded disappointed.

"I'll take an exam over throwing knives," another kid answered Himiko. "I never had good aim."

Rows of caretakers then appeared. One for each of them.

The caretakers looked different now. They were dressed in all white still, but they had long, intimidating rifles strapped to their backs. In their hands was a metal clipboard and on their face was a mask. The mask was made of porcelain, obstructing their faces and only allowing a small gateway to their lifeless eyes.

Izuku shivered. It was eerie.

Their designated caretaker escorted them to the tiny desk area and stood directly behind them. There were exactly two pencils and a thick packet. Izuku peered behind him, and his unknown caretaker stared down at him.

“Begin,” Nine commanded.

Izuku didn’t write right away, and he could hear the caretaker behind him make a mark on their clipboard. Quickly, Izuku shook himself out of his mind and opened up the packet. He skimmed through it and when he realized that this was all life situations he understood the gist.

They’re testing us for our emotions, Izuku thought quietly. *They’re weeding out weakness.*

He thought about all the times he had been disciplined for showing negative emotions like kindness and crying then began answering the questions carefully. As he read through the booklet, he kept seeing scenarios from his romance novel. What the people did in that book was entirely different than how he assumed his family would want him to act.

Izuku answered every question with the opposite of what he would do.

He even thought quietly about what Tomura would do—the meanest person he knew.

Many of his own answers made Izuku wince.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku handed his packet to Ms. Nagant and she stared down at him as if he wasn’t there. The caretaker who was assigned to him directed him to a small room off to the side with the other kids and they all waited. It took hours for them to grade their tests. When the door opened, Mr. Compress was standing there with a clipboard and blank expression.

“If I call your name, please come with me,” Mr. Compress announced. Everyone held their breath. Name after name was called and slowly the room began thinning out. Izuku gazed on, unsure why but dread sank further and further into his stomach the longer his own name wasn’t called.

Then when the last name was called, Izuku looked around.

About 2/3^{rds} of them were left. Izuku surveyed the ones left and found Himiko, Sen and several other people he recognized and many he didn’t.

Nine then stepped into the room with the Governor.

“Congratulations, to everyone in this room,” Nine said with a hint of satisfaction. “You all passed the examination well enough, and you will continue on to the next stage of The Cull.”

An eruption of excited whispers broke out.

“E-Excuse me,” one boy timidly chimed. He raised his hand. “I-I have a question.”

Izuku turned his head, wondering who would be dumb enough to speak directly to Nine. There he saw a shy seeming boy with stark blond hair and purple eyes. He was a little bit bigger than Izuku and was curled into himself as if unsure of what he was about to say.

“Yes?” Mr. Compress answered.

“Um,” The boy cleared his throat when all eyes were on him. He held his stomach like there was a bad ache. “Wh-What will happen to the others? My other b-brother was a part of the names called.”

“They didn’t make the cut to be apart of the Mamushi family,” Ms. Nagant cut in. Her eyes narrowed. “That was it.”

“A-Are they going back home?” The unnamed boy pressed. “I want to say goodbye to him.”

“I’m afraid that’s not possible,” Nine spoke up this time. “They will be going elsewhere. You will not be seeing them ever again.”

The boy clenched his jaw and held back tears.

“Are there any more questions?” Nine asked sternly. He crawled his eyes over everyone’s face and was met with silence. He nodded. “Glad that is out of the way. Now please follow the caretakers for where you’ll be sleeping for the night.”

Izuku followed the caretakers, but not before glancing over his shoulder at the boy.

He felt bad for him.

ᔓᔓᔓ

That night they were all given new clothes. Every single one of them was given gray sweats with the symbol of a snake on the back, much like their clothes at home for training. Afterwards they were shoved into an elevator and lowered into the ground. They were brought to a large room with rows and rows of tiny beds and told to pick one.

Izuku’s nature led him to automatically linger behind the boy who had asked the question about his missing brother. Izuku didn’t speak to him, but he surveyed the other curiously out of concern. The blond boy had his head hanging low and he walked over to the corner of the room with the bed furthest away from the crowd.

Izuku took the bed next to him quietly and laid his head against the pillow.

Across the way Sen and Himiko were bragging about how well they answered the questions in the exam. They had gathered a crowd of other children and Izuku watched on in silence.

“Do you know them?” The boy finally spoke beside him.

Izuku rolled over to see the blond boy sitting up in his bed, clutching the sheets nervously.

“I do,” Izuku said quietly. “We’re on the same floor.”

The boy nodded. “What floor are you from?”

“I’m from floor ten,” Izuku said. He rolled over with a smile. “How about you?”

“I’m from floor eight.” The boy smiled back at him and seemed to un-tense. “I’ve seen you around a couple of times recently, but I don’t think you’ve ever noticed me. I usually train in the back corner with my Big sometimes at night. You’re Tomura’s little brother right?”

Izuku nodded. “Yeah. My name is Izuku.”

The boy held his hand out and his purple eyes sparkled with kindness.

“Nice to meet you Izuku, I’m Aoyama.”

ɯɯɯ

The next morning, they were brought to a cafeteria. There weren’t many details given to them, but the caretakers were aligned in rows against the walls.

It made Izuku feel cramped and as if there were thousands of eyes dancing across his skin. He stuck side by side with Aoyama for the rest of the day as they took a seat in the corner away from the loudness of Sen and Himiko.

“Good morning everyone,” Mr. Compress announced loudly to the cafeteria. He was void of his signature grin. Next to him was the Governor and Nine. “Today we will be doing some physical activities and examining your training skills. Please be sure to eat up today to make sure you have enough energy to perform at your best.”

The caretakers then stepped forward and placed down golden trays of breakfast food in front of them. Izuku was curiously waiting for the daily green smoothie to be given, but it wasn’t. They were given water instead.

“Wow, the food looks great today,” Aoyama muttered beside him. “I guess they really want to make sure we do our best.”

Izuku nodded. “It looks like they gave us extra serving too!”

Both boys giggled and picked up their utensils to begin eating.

Izuku hummed in delight when he plopped a bit of egg in his mouth. He always loved food and enjoyed everything they were served. Both him and Aoyama ate every single last bit of

food on their plates as did every kid in the room in preparation for the day.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When they were brought to the physical testing area by the caretakers. It was spacious and exactly the same as the one at home but more intense. There were knife throwing stations. Shooting ranges were off to the very far side and there was an obstacle course set up perfectly with no cushions.

Mr. Compress told them their first task was to jog around for an hour. This would get them warmed up.

Izuku easily jogged beside Aoyama when the clock started. The two talked casually but then a pain filled groan filled the air. Izuku's eyes widened with fear when Aoyama clutched his stomach and staggered.

"Hey, are you okay?" Izuku whispered when his new companion stopped jogging entirely.

Aoyama tried to answer him but instead of words, pain filled grunts came out.

"I-I'm fine," Aoyama hissed eventually. His voice was breathless as he doubled over and fell to his knees. "G-Go. Keep jogging, Izuku. They're watching and you could get in trouble for helping me. You know helping is punishable."

Izuku hesitated.

Aoyama was right but Izuku didn't want to leave someone behind who was hurt.

Izuku peered around and it was then he saw one caretaker staring at him, taking notes. Izuku bit the inside of his cheek and then started jogging again, leaving the blond boy behind him.

But he couldn't entirely drown out the nagging voice in his head telling him he was a bad person for leaving a friend behind. Izuku peaked over his shoulder to see Aoyama attempting to steady his breathing as many other kids jogged around him.

Then something odd began happening.

Izuku eased his jogging as if everything was moving in slow motion.

One by one kids all around him began clutching their stomachs.

Some powered through it and continued to run. Others fell to their knees and curled into balls crying. Others started heaving and clawing at their skin and suddenly others vomited on the ground. All around him sickness filled the facility as everyone began dropping like flies, releasing a putrid smell of vomit into the air.

Izuku gasped, whirling in full rotation in horror and held his hand over his nose.

Everyone was becoming sick. Izuku started hyperventilating, waiting and waiting for it to hit him—but it never came. Izuku's eyes were full of fear as he looked for Sen and Himiko to

see if they had succumbed to it as well. But they both still were jogging but holding their stomachs. Himiko's expression was pinched in pain and Sen looked nearly blue in the face.

Izuku picked up his pace, keeping his hand tightly enclosed around his nose. He sidestepped vomit and bodies on the ground. Kids were crying hysterically. Caretakers soon were out on the floor cleaning and carrying away kids who were too weak to go on.

Izuku turned his head, searching for Aoyama and found his new friend slowly jogging—but jogging.

After the hour—more than half of the kids were no longer there.

Izuku was the only one who ran perfectly undisturbed.

Many eyes were on him after that. Particularly, Nine was surveying him curiously.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Later that evening, everyone who hadn't passed out during the run was tested on their normal activities.

Izuku scored perfectly in knife throwing and the shooting range. He even did the extra activity of using the double guns for extra points. Over the course of the hours, the kids who had stomach aches pushed through it to still perform which earned a nod of approval from Ms. Nagant who was watching them.

Then afterwards they were each separately asked to give speeches in Japanese, Korean, Mandarin, Thai, Spanish and English. Izuku's nerves made him push through his lisp and stutter while under the eyes of Nine.

When they all returned back to their beds, several were empty. Izuku stared around at the few remaining and here he could see there were only a handful of them. Many kids who had passed out had been taken away and others who didn't score adequately on the physical examination were also asked to leave the building.

Later that night, Izuku watched Himiko stick a finger in her mouth.

When she pulled it back, there was blood.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When the next day came, they were given another serving of food for breakfast. Everyone was weary of it and picked at it with caution. Izuku poked at his eggs, and curiously nipped on them. After an hour, nothing happened, and no one was falling over with stomach aches. The kids ate up the whole meal, ready to get on with the next day of events.

After their breakfast, they were then escorted into another elevator. They were lowered deep into the ground, and Izuku watched how the numbers sank further and further. Goosebumps slowly arose on his skin when he saw how far they were going.

“What do you think will be next?” Aoyama whispered to Izuku.

“I’m not sure,” Izuku muttered.

Izuku turned his head in the crowded elevator. He glanced up at the caretakers and their faceless masks. The elevator dinged and the rustic doors opened up. Then they were shuffled out into a scene Izuku would have never anticipated.

They were deep underground in an abandoned subway track.

The atmosphere was grayish green, overran with dirt and debris. It was large enough to fit at least five trains, making the concrete around them feel spacious. But Izuku wasn’t sure what to think of that. The train tracks were rusted on every inch of the metal. Then the caretakers told them to move until they were standing in the middle of the tracks. Directly in front of them was a large wooden stand, entirely out of place.

The elevator dinged behind them again, and more kids were brought down.

Once they were all gathered, heavy footsteps caught their attention.

Standing tall like a king, was Nine. His hands were behind his back, and his eyes were scrutinizing every single one of them. Izuku’s spine stiffened, and Aoyama slightly hid behind him.

Everyone waited for him to speak, but nothing happened. Instead, the caretakers started distributing tiny, black backpacks to them. Izuku frowned deeply at this, but took the bag, nonetheless. Aoyama did too with caution and Himiko did it with eagerness.

Once the caretakers finished, they all lined up like objects on a shelf.

Izuku glanced at Nine who was looking directly at him.

Everyone else around him began whispering as they opened up the pouches they were given. Out came knives, Band-Aids, and different types of first aid supplies. Izuku’s heart plummeted straight into the ground when it was clear what this was.

“*Survive*,” Tomura’s warning rang clear in his head.

Izuku swallowed as he opened up his own pouch.

Six knives. Five Band-Aids. A flashlight.

This was a survival test—and it was going to be violent.

“Welcome to the final part of The Cull,” Nine welcomed. “Congratulations are in order for you all making it this far.”

Beside him the Governor, Ms. Nagant and Mr. Compress walked up dutifully. Everyone marveled at them, but Izuku didn’t. He stared them down as he looked at the shiny metal in the backpack. His pulse quickened as Nine continued his speech.

“In a very special year, fifty of you have made it to the final part of this exam. However, we can only take in thirty as official members of the Mamushi family. This means there will be twenty of you who will not make the cut and be sent away with the others who didn’t pass.”

Gasps. Shudders. Whispers.

Nine pointed down into the long tunnel of the train tracks. Darkness stared back at them as the tunnels went into the deepest part of the underground.

“The first thirty to make it to the end of these tracks will be in the family and obtain the marks,” Nine announced. “The twenty who do not make it will be sent away from our care to suffer for the rest of their lives. Due to how serious this is, we will allow free reign. Do whatever you must do to ensure your spot. There are no limits or rules.”

Sen raised his hand.

Izuku’s stomach felt sick.

“Yes, Sen?” Mr. Compress called upon him. “Did you have a question?”

“Can we hurt the others to make sure we make it?” Sen questioned.

Izuku cut his eye to the other boy and staring right back at him like a twisted reflection was Sen. He was grinning with all of his teeth, mirroring his Big Brother, Jin. Izuku’s gut twisted terribly because that’s exactly how Jin smiled right before severely hurting someone.

“Yes,” Nine confirmed. “You all may do what you must. All that matters is that you are the first thirty to make it across to the finish line. There are no rules.”

Murmurs of violent delights swept across the crowd.

Izuku stayed frozen, and he realized that this was the real cull. The slaughter of the weak who were not suited to be a Mamushi.

“On my mark you will begin,” Nine commanded.

Izuku looked to his right, and he could see Aoyama’s eyes stretched wide with both fear and desperate need for belonging. His new friend glanced at him only once and then he turned his head towards the darkness in front of them.

Izuku knew then their brief friendship had simmered down to nothing now that it was everyone for themselves.

“One.” Nine held up his hand and everyone secured the backpacks to their bodies. “Two.” Everyone took sprinting positions, and focused. “Three.” Not a single soul breathed. “*Run*.”

Forty-nine bodies took off into the darkness willingly. But one stayed behind.

Izuku stood there, in the cloud of dust that was kicked up. He watched in disbelief as all of his siblings were swallowed by the various pathways of darkness, not even bothering to look

back. Izuku did however, and he stared straight up at the adults looking at him. They were studying him as though he was stupid. Except Nine. Nine was staring at him curiously.

“Izuku, was it?” Nine questioned. He tilted his head. “You’re 117’s little brother, correct?”

“Correct,” Izuku confirmed.

“I’m interested in seeing how you perform,” Nine drawled out in his deep voice. “You’ve already been outstanding. But I expect no less from the little brother of the top student at the Viper Academy.”

Izuku knew a threat when he heard one.

That was a harsh reminder that his success was not his alone—it was Tomura’s as well.

He slowly strapped the backpack to his person. Then Izuku took a deep breath and plunged himself forward into the darkness.

Immediately his eyes strained, and his nose scrunched. There was barely any light down here and it smelled of rotten mildew. The few spotlights that were in the ceiling flickered with a yellowish tint that helped nothing. Izuku could vaguely see the rats on the ground that were scurrying about. When Izuku reached the crossroads, the five separate tracks led into five separate tunnels.

He could hear the voices of his siblings deep inside already. Many kids were tussling, screaming, and shouting that they had gone the wrong direction. Glimmers of distant flashlights were all over, waving like people were in distress.

Izuku then took a step back and looked at the five separate pathways.

He took out his flashlight and surveyed the five pillars that separated the different tunnels. There was nothing special about these pillars, however when Izuku flickered his flashlight up to the top of the one in the corner—he found their sigil spray painted at the top. He furrowed his brow at how discreet it was and then shone his light down the other four tunnels.

He walked down the branded one.

This tunnel was emptier than the rest it seemed. Behind him were the panicked voices of other kids who figured out they had gone down the wrong way. Izuku then thought about Tomura and his heart pulled in fear that his Big Brother may be hurt if he failed.

Izuku began to jog lightly, desperate to get to the finish line.

He moved through the various tunnels, trying not to give away he figured out to look for a viper symbol. It helped guide him down the winding tunnels that wove into each other like needle and thread.

The tunnels rotated between long narrow pathways of long tracks to large spaces of abandoned train carts waiting in the open on multiple railways. It almost seemed like a

graveyard. The forgotten contraptions of metal were stacked on top of each other in different orders, making a strange obstacle course to navigate.

Then when he came upon one tunnel, he could hear a sickening sound of squelching not too far away.

The ominous laughter of Sen and Himiko mixed together.

Izuku flicked off his flashlight and melted into the shadows against the wall.

From his position, he could see a gruesome image. Himiko was holding another kid by the arms and Sen drove a knife into his stomach. The other kid screamed, thrashing harshly trying to throw them off. He begged for his life but neither Sen or Himiko eased up. Sen pulled out his blade that was now dressed in blood and expertly slashed it across the boy's throat.

Red blood rained down on both of them.

They didn't flinch. Himiko even closed her eyes and relished it as though she had been waiting to do this forever.

"Killing does feel as good as Ms. Nagant says it does," Himiko rejoiced. Izuku had to put his hand over his mouth to prevent from gagging out loud. "We should kill Izuku next, Sen."

Sen smiled sinisterly. "You read my mind. I bet that runt hasn't made it this far yet. We should backtrack a bit to try to find him."

"But won't that put us at risk of not making the cut?"

Sen sharply laughed. "We can kill some others on the way to even it out."

Izuku held his breath as they walked towards him and he crouched low. He slid underneath one empty train cart, laid on his belly and watched in fear. Sen and Himiko started calling out his name like he was a lost puppy they wanted to come home.

Then another kid rounded the corner, unexpectedly running full speed. Sen gleefully slung his knife directly between the boy's eyes, and Himiko's grin widened.

The body dropped dead in an instant as blood poured down the face.

Sen and Himiko walked away holding hands, laughing about it.

Izuku clasped his hand over his mouth in horror. He frantically stared at the endless darkness engulfing him and at the tunnel road ahead. He crawled quickly and quietly from underneath the train cart and began jogging deeper into the cavern. As Izuku was walking, he heard the quiet sound of faint crying. His pace slowed, and he knew he should keep going—selfishness was needed.

But he couldn't.

A flash of Kacchan crying appeared in his mind.

Izuku stopped his pace entirely.

He searched around, pulled by a clutching in his heart that was triggered. Izuku took a chance and turned on his flashlight to quietly scan around for the source of the crying. When he squatted down low, he found the source and it was a blond-haired boy, underneath another train cart with his face in the dirt.

Izuku furrowed his brow, and he tried his best not to compare how similar this boy looked to how Kacchan did when he first found him. Whoever it was covered in dirt and his blond hair and clothes were dingy. Izuku's heart strung tightly. He moved his flashlight towards the weeping boy and immediately the boy flinched and lifted his head.

Terrified purple eyes stared back at Izuku.

Purple. Not red.

It was Aoyama.

"Please don't hurt me," Aoyama whispered. He held up his hand to shield his eyes from the blinding flashlight. "P-Please I promise I won't cross over."

"Aoyama, it's me. Izuku," Izuku reassured. He flicked off his flashlight. "C'mon, we have to go now before someone comes back."

The blond boy violently shook his head.

"Leave me here," Aoyama cried. "I-I'm not suited for this. I'm too weak. I'm not at all like the others. Y-You didn't see how they tore each other apart. So many of them started shoving each other, then punching and kicking. Then it turned to a full-on brawl. I-It's horrible."

"Then that's even more reason to get up," Izuku hissed. He glanced over his shoulder weary. "If you stay here you might *die*."

"I heard that if we're sent away we're dead too," Aoyama gravely retorted. He was rocking slightly, holding his head. "Th-There's no winning. We're trapped. Trapped like animals."

"We have no clue if that's true," Izuku shot back. "It's better to at least make it to the finish line and be sent away than die here for sure. Please. Get up. I don't want to leave you here."

Izuku held out his hand for Aoyama.

The other boy stared at him like he had gone crazy for offering up altruism. Izuku didn't flinch at his stare, he knew that they were taught not to do this, but a light inside of Izuku forced him to. He couldn't ignore it otherwise the guilt in his chest would always eat him alive.

Aoyama took his hand. Izuku pulled him out from underneath the cart and they began to run off into the darkness. They both kept their hands clasped together in fear and kinship. Both

boys used their flashlights and began working together. Aoyama led Izuku and Izuku led him back in the correct directions and the two of them were able to inch closer and closer to the finish line.

They came to a fork in the road eventually.

Two tunnels, one with a blinking red light and one with a green light.

Automatically, Aoyama started towards the one with the green light, but Izuku stopped him. Izuku shook his head and pulled on their interlocked hands. He jutted his head towards the tunnel with the red light.

“The Viper symbols have been painted in red,” Izuku explained. “And I think it would be too obvious to walk towards the green light. I don’t think Nine would be that straightforward.”

Aoyama hummed in agreement, and they began walking towards the blinking red light together. As they walked, there was no one else. Behind them were the sounds of distant screaming, or kids crying and begging to be let out from the maze. But they walked calmly towards that flashing red symbol, and Izuku hoped with all his heart that this would be the end of their nightmare.

“Thank you for helping me back there,” Aoyama said as they walked through the tunnel. “You’re nicer than you should be.”

Izuku shrugged. “I don’t know how not to be.”

“I think that’s alright.” Aoyama smiled at him, and Izuku smiled back. They walked through a larger tunnel with several train carts stacked high in the darkness. “I appreciate you helping a lot. I was ready to give up. So, thank you. I owe you a favor sometime in the future if you ever want it.”

He was about to reject the other boy’s offer when suddenly the rushing of footsteps behind them could be heard.

Both boys whipped their heads at the sudden onset of screams. Kids were running full speed, being chased by Himiko and Sen with knives being slung at them. Izuku locked eyes with Sen, who then grinned like a monster.

“Himiko! There’s the runt!” Sen announced.

He pointed a finger directly at Izuku and Izuku’s heart plummeted.

“Run,” Izuku whispered.

Both Aoyama and Izuku took off into the darkness, flashlights waving around without purpose. Behind them Sen and Himiko followed in hot pursuit. The two others were taunting them, screaming out his name like demons hungry for flesh.

Izuku pushed his body fast and Aoyama did too, and their hands eventually broke apart as they took off as quickly as they could towards the red light.

Behind them, a full crowd of other children caught up—all running directly towards the red light.

Izuku yelped as a knife was flung close to his head. He looked behind him to see Himiko grinning with feral blood lust. She was slinging endless knives it seemed. She probably stole them from everyone they killed. When the next knife throw nearly hit Aoyama, Izuku took a risk.

“Go towards the finish line!” Izuku instructed.

Aoyama’s eyes widened in horror, but it didn’t take him long to decide to do exactly that.

Izuku broke apart from Aoyama for his safety and just like he suspected, Sen and Himiko were on his heels.

He ducked around train carts for safety as it hailed down deadly knives. Izuku struggled to catch his breath as he maneuvered as fast as he could in the dark. He flicked off his flashlight in hopes of losing them, but the echo of the twin laughs surrounded him.

Izuku gritted his teeth as he relied on his quick thinking to get him across the finish line. He looked up at the train cart he was hiding behind and an idea sprung into his head.

Izuku ran forward when he heard Sen and Himiko’s footsteps draw close.

He leaped for the nearest train cart and began climbing it.

“He’s going up there!” Himiko announced. Izuku looked behind him and he could see the two break apart to hunt him down. He climbed quicker when Sen went straight for him. Himiko began climbing a parallel train cart.

Izuku stumbled to the roof of the train cart and began running. He leaped from roof to roof and barreled right for the red light. In view he could see several handfuls of other kids begin to cross the finish line. His blood went cold with adrenaline as his anxiety peaked. Then he screamed as a sharp knife was plunged into his arm.

Izuku toppled forward, body dragging across the rustic metal. He yelled loudly as his face was scraped and immediately Sen was on him. Izuku struggled back and forth with the other boy, blocking punches and taking several hits to the face.

Sen was stronger than him and filled with so much bloodlust Izuku could taste it in his mouth. Without taking too long, Sen got the upper hand. The other boy was pinning him down on the ground face first. He hit Izuku’s head against the metal surface over and over again with a wicked laugh.

“Kill him, Sen! Kill him!” Himiko cheered on across the way.

Izuku nearly puked. He was dizzy—and he didn’t know how much longer he could hang on.

In his ears The Dance of The Love Birds rang out, comforting him with every blow to the head.

“Go across the finish line, Himiko!” Sen instructed. “I’ll meet you there. Secure your spot!”

Himiko sprung across the rooftops of the train carts as Izuku began bleeding out of his nose. He gasped when his mind fogged over, and he could see sweet Kacchan waiting for him. Maybe he could die here, and then he could search for Kacchan in the afterlife—if there was one. Maybe then Izuku could know peace.

But then a visual of Tomura sunk into his mind.

Sen chuckled deeply as he turned Izuku over. He drank in the battered face he had caused and smirked. Sen twirled his knife and Izuku could see his reflection staring back at it in the dim light.

“Goodbye, Izuku,” Sen taunted.

He thrusted his blade down, and Izuku acted as fast as he could. He grabbed Sen by his wrist the moment the tip of the blade scratched his jugular. They gridlocked in a test of strength in will. Izuku’s head and heart pounded in sync as he locked eyes with the boy above him.

“Survive,” the voice of Tomura whispered.

Izuku grew stronger.

“Survive,” the voice of Tomura harshly demanded.

Izuku furrowed his brow.

“Survive!” the voice of Tomura yelled.

Izuku screamed as he lunged forward.

He seized the knife from Sen and slashed at the other boy. Sen quickly dodged back, but not far enough as the blade ripped through his shirt and flesh across his chest. Blood leaked down onto Izuku but he didn’t take the time to assess it.

Before Sen could retaliate, Izuku head butted Sen straight on, breaking the other boy’s nose. He then grabbed Sen by the wrist and twisted it counterclockwise, exactly like Hiryu had told him to—and the sound of bone breaking reached his ear. Sen screamed, and tried to punch him, but Izuku caught his fist.

Izuku pushed through the agonizing pain in his body. He ignored the dots in his vision as he did a full roundhouse kick, slamming his heel into Sen’s temple.

It happened all so fast.

Izuku had only meant to defend himself, but the gasp from Sen as he toppled off the train cart was deafening. The other boy fell straight off, and his head hit the side of the train cart parallel. Down he went, cracking several bones until his body hit the ground with a hard thud.

Izuku was too nauseous to react right away. He lurched forward to his hands and knees to catch his breath. In the distance he heard kids running for the finish line. With his last bit of strength, Izuku glanced over the train cart.

His heart dropped.

Sen's body was lying on the ground, slowly being engulfed in a pool of blood.



Izuku walked towards the red light with his eyes wide. He was shaking with every step he took as the repeated sound of bone breaking happened over and over again in his head. Sen's distorted body flashed upon him unwillingly and the blood on his hands reminded him what occurred.

What have you done?! Izuku's conscience screamed at him.

He stumbled towards the red light and crossed over the finish line.

Izuku fell to his knees and put a hand over his pounding heart.

The walls in his vision grew tighter, and the whole world warped as though he was trapped with no air in a cellar. In front of him a handful of other kids were gathered, looking off behind him as a couple more people filtered in. Nine, Ms. Nagant, Mr. Compress and the Governor were there too. All the adults were gazing at him curiously.

It was then Izuku realized he had been covered in an obscene amount of blood.

Sen's blood.

Then one last kid ran across the white line.

"Thirty," A caretaker off to the side announced. The man put his hand up to signal to Nine. "That concludes the final test of The Cull."

Several more kids ran towards them, but they were stopped by strong armed caretakers. They broke down crying, pleading for another chance to stay. Nine didn't bother looking at them as they were taken away. Many other kids trickled in like a broken faucet leaking. Drip by drip the left-over boys and girls were escorted elsewhere.

"Where's Sen?" Himiko questioned.

She pushed towards the front of the crowd, and everyone began whispering. Her golden eyes flickered with confusion. Even Ms. Nagant's did. Izuku dared to glance up from his spot on the ground, and it was then Himiko finally noticed him covered in dirt and blood.

Her face grew pale.

"Where is Sen?" She asked a lot more forcefully.

She stalked up to Izuku and grabbed him by his collar when he didn't answer. Izuku shook his head and screwed his eyes closed, expecting a hit. But nothing came. His head spun as he aggressively shook, but all he could hear was white noise blending with the cracks in Himiko's vocal cords.

"Where is Sen, you stupid runt?!" Himiko cried. Her hands began shaking as she stared at him in horror. "He was going to kill you! He was *supposed* to kill you!"

The blood on his shirt told enough of a story that Izuku didn't think he needed to speak.

Everyone was glancing at them, eyes darting between Izuku and the darkness. When no more kids came to the finish line, Nine gave the order for the caretakers to find any bodies. He wanted a full headcount of the kids who didn't make it back. They all sat there in silence, Himiko desperately watching as the caretakers began to carry back limb children.

Izuku's stomach was sick when more than ten dead bodies were dragged into view.

Sen, being one of them.

The shrillness of Himiko's cry caused everyone to flinch.

She tried to push her way towards Sen's body but was stopped by a caretaker.

She clawed at them and swiped at their mask. The porcelain object shattered to the ground, revealing the face of the person underneath. Cold, heartless eyes burned into Himiko and she was slapped for her outburst. Everyone turned their heads as Himiko stumbled backwards from the sheer force. She crumbled to the hard ground of the dirt, crying with all of the emotions inside of her.

She didn't get back up, and Izuku could feel her pain from here.

She wept softly, knowing that she would be punished later. But she didn't care. All she could do was watch as Sen's lifeless body was laid next to the others.

When the blanket was pulled over his face, Nine appeared next to Izuku.

"Were you the one who killed Sen?" Nine asked in an inquisitive tone.

Izuku let out a shaky breath. All eyes were on him again, and his throat still too clammed up to speak. He stared down at his hands that were covered in Sen's blood.

"Y-Yes," Izuku croaked out. "I-I did it."

Nine tilted his head at him and nodded once in approval. "Good job."

Their head father walked away and towards the caretakers to give instructions.

Izuku glanced over his shoulder at the grieving girl. Himiko was gritting her teeth. Her bloody fists were clenched, and her hair was askew. One of her buns had come undone and

the locks of hair had fallen down to her shoulder. The fire in her eyes blazed like a hundred infernos melting into one.

Run, was the first thought Izuku had underneath that glare of hers. But he couldn't move. He was paralyzed in place with goosebumps dancing along his limbs.

The caretakers then walked over to Himiko and forced her upright. They grabbed her arms to drag her away for the punishment of crying and assaulting the caretaker. She didn't struggle. She bit her lip to stop her crying and held her head up high, poised with a murderous grace. She allowed herself to be pulled away quietly and all her tears halted.

When they passed by Izuku, she muttered a threat that was as deadly as her.

"I'll kill you for this," Himiko promised.

They locked eyes as she passed. She was walked off into a different tunnel, consumed by darkness.

Izuku held his breath as guilt crashed down on his shoulders.

What have you done? Izuku's conscious whispered.

ᔓᔓᔓ

After the final round, they were all transported to a small classroom. Thirty of them made it when nearly a hundred of them started. Everyone was assessing each other as true members of their family now.

Some kids were still too shaken to speak. Others were happy and chatting.

They brought Himiko back out, and she had a large black eye. She was disheveled, but someone had fixed her hair for her.

Immediately when Himiko sat down, she cut her golden glare to Izuku and ice trickled down his spine.

"Congratulations to everyone here in this room, you're officially a part of the family!" Mr. Compress said happily. He clapped his hands together as they were all given warm blankets and food. "Wow. You all did amazing, I'm so proud of you!"

Mostly everyone cheered and glowed at the praise.

Izuku and Aoyama didn't, some of the few too shaken to speak. The pair exchanged discreet stares as they glanced around, still on high alert. Izuku's stomach was twisting from the sickening visuals of dead bodies and the smell of the blood that had gotten into his mind. Izuku couldn't eat the food given to him. He settled for moving around the peas on the plate with his fork to make it seem like he was.

Whenever he blinked, he could see Sen's broken body and Himiko's similarly broken expression.

He hung his head as his hands trembled out of control.

"As an official member of the Mamushi family, it's time you learn the special purpose our family has in this world," Mr. Compress said.

Special purpose? This piqued everyone's attention.

Suddenly, rows of caretakers in blank masks came out and Izuku's skin began to crawl.

"As you know, the world is full of terrible, cruel people," Mr. Compress lectured like always. "People who turn on each other, lie to each other, and deserve *no* sympathy or mercy. You are all here because these horrible people tossed you aside as babies. We have taken you in and saved you, given you life. Because of this, it is our family that has been blessed with the task of helping eliminate these kinds of awful people who scorned you."

"Eliminate?" Izuku questioned before he could stop himself.

Everyone turned to him. Mr. Compress smiled stiffly.

"*Kill*," Mr. Compress elaborated. "We are tasked to kill the horrible people in the world."

Izuku's whole body froze and dropped his fork at the same time everyone else cheered.

He whirled around, confused why everyone was cheering. Then it all began to click together. All the pieces aligned, and he gravely understood what was happening—or more importantly—what they were being asked to do.

Even Aoyama next to him didn't seem phased. He clapped softly too, nodding.

Izuku was the only one put off.

"You will begin your real training from here on out," Mr. Compress said. "Now. Let's give you all your marks."

Right before Izuku could speak up, suddenly he was stuck with something sharp in the base of his neck. Izuku screamed in unison with everyone else taken by surprise. He slumped forward as he could feel an unknown substance pushed under his skin. Izuku's throat slammed shut and his eyes bulged. He stared up at the caretaker who was faceless behind that porcelain mask.

Izuku panicked—and when he panicked, he tried to keep calm.

The last thing he thought of was blond hair and red eyes as his head hit the floor.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku awoke in a cold sweat.

He screamed as he sat forward and hugged his arms close to his body. He stared around, and realized he was in a small room with the others who had survived. Everyone looked disheveled, confused and all of their clothes were missing. In place they were in light blue hospital gowns.

Izuku twisted and immediately felt pain all over his body and on his collarbone.

He snapped his head down, still disoriented. He was bandaged in various places from where he was injured in the last round of The Cull. His arm was in a cast from where Sen had twisted it and he had several bandages on his arms and legs.

Izuku frowned. He pushed his finger into one he didn't recall receiving, right on his inner thigh.

He poked at it, and it stung deeply like he had been cut there. He wondered if maybe one of Himiko's knives had stuck in him and he hadn't fully registered it in his haze of panic.

Then Izuku's attention was grabbed fully by the mirror across the way. Many kids were gathered around, whispering and pointing to different places on their bodies. Izuku stood to his feet, slightly limping from the litany of pain sparking all over his body. He walked straight up through the crowd to the dingy mirror, and he could see black ink on everyone's skin that wasn't there before.

Izuku felt empty when he looked around and caught sight of everyone's mark.

Himiko's was 200 on her ankle.

Aoyama's was 215 on his wrist.

And Izuku's was 217 on his collar bone.

Chapter End Notes

Let me know what you think below! I'm very eagar for feedback, comments, and thoughts on this since this is the first Izuku POV and we're getting into it. Thanks so much for reading and commenting!

Chapter 18: Entr'acte II

Chapter Summary

Izuku earns his Viper title.

Chapter Notes

Helloooo! Welcome back to the choocoo of angst!! Big thank you to the LOML Luna for betaing like always!!

Also big thank you to everyone who commented and interacted on the previous chapter! I will respond to comments directly after posting this chapter :') I had a bit of a draining week and needed some down time to just stare at the ceiling but I still want to make sure I reply back to everyone like usual because I really do appreciate you all so much!! I'm so excited for Izuku's POV and digging into Viper Academy lore and set up.

Without further delay, I hope you enjoy reading!

Warnings: Heavy angst and graphic scene. Implied sexual assault, no description of it, but it is very subtly implied.

See the end of the chapter for more notes



Art by [RokuZero]

Chapter 18 — [Entr'acte II]

.

.

.

The boat ride to the mainland left Izuku feeling seasick. His whole world had turned upside down, and he was trapped inside a nightmare he never thought was possible. He had been so worried about trying to survive, but now—he wished he had been killed.

The sway of the bus into Tokyo creaked as hallow as his bones.

He barely blinked the entire time and next to him was Aoyama, who only seemed relieved to be alive. But how could Izuku be relived he was alive when he was only breathing to cause suffering? Izuku blankly stared at his subtle reflection in the window of the bus. The faint

outline of himself was like a ghost staring back at him—and for a moment he saw Sen instead.

"Looks like you took my spot after all, runt," the ghost of Sen said from the glass.

Izuku jerked back when the sinister reflection smiled cruelly at him. Aoyama looked at him strangely and Izuku wanted to peel the number 217 off his skin. Instead, he kept his head down as whispers from the thirty official siblings sparked all around him.

He killed Sen, and no one expected it.

When they arrived back at their home, several Big Sisters and Brothers were waiting for them in the lobby. Eagerness was bouncing around their sterile white walls as everyone waited to see who made the cut.

Izuku looked in the crowd of familiar faces for Tomura—but he wasn't there.

He watched as Ibara stared in the crowd for her Little. Ibara kept a beautifully blank face when she found they weren't there, like she expected nothing less. Her shoulders sagged a bit, but not too much.

Next Izuku watched as Hiryu went around checking for his Little, who also didn't make it. He was the boy Sen had gutted open with the help of Himiko.

Slowly, disappointment bubbled inside of Izuku as he watched Himiko be reunited with her big, Kuin. Kuin was someone Izuku always forgot about, but she had an air about her like a Queen Bee. Her teeth had been sharpened with a chiseled knife and her eyepatch was always hidden under the flop of her brown bangs. The lone green eye she had was always quietly watching, distantly.

Usually Kuin usually never touched other people, but at that moment, she gave Himiko a small pat on the shoulder. Himiko glowed.

Izuku watched everyone be reunited or torn apart as he was left alone.

Hiryu caught sight of him and there was a small spark of surprise in his eyes. Izuku offered him a weak smile as Hiryu grinned at him. He gave Izuku a nod and thumbs up, but Izuku couldn't return the enthusiasm.

Had Hiryu known this whole time? Had *all* the Bigs?

Jin stepped into his view and that was the final push.

Guilt crashed down like a tidal wave and drowned him alive. Behind Jin, Izuku imagined the horrific, bloodied phantom of Sen. The dead boy's head was split open from where he hit the side of the train cart and his arm was twisted in an unnatural direction. Sen had the same, sick smile on his face even in death.

Jin marched around, unknowing to the shadow Izuku was hallucinating. One by one, Jin checked all the faces of the children who were in the lobby until he walked up to Himiko.

“Where’s Sen?” Jin asked quietly.

He was baffled. This was not an outcome Jin thought was possible, and Izuku didn’t blame him. He couldn’t believe it either. Himiko didn’t say anything right away, her eyes were red and puffy. There were dark circles under her eyes and several stray pieces of dirt in her perfectly blond hair.

“Himiko…what happened to Sen?” Jin pushed again.

Her sharp, hateful eyes turned to Izuku—as did everyone else’s.

Hiryu frowned in confusion.

Himiko pointed a finger without shame at Izuku and whispered inaudibly.

Izuku didn’t need to hear what she was saying, he knew it. His suspicions were confirmed when grief rippled across Jin’s face. Forbidden tears pushed at Jin’s eyes but didn’t fall. His pride and joy was now dead, and there was only one person responsible. Jin clutched his hands and his deadly gaze inched towards Izuku.

Jin then smiled at Izuku with all of his teeth.

Himiko’s spiteful, bloodshot eyes were on him too. No smile in sight.

The phantom of Sen laughed between them. He dragged his thumb across his throat and smiled with blood caked on his teeth.

“I’ll see you in death, runt,” Sen taunted.

Izuku could feel the knives Himiko and Jin wanted to sink into him. Or the acid they would probably force down his throat. He wondered if they would get a kick out of drowning him or go the simple route of snapping his neck in his sleep. Izuku pandered his eventual death at the hands of the two people who cared most for Sen.

But he didn’t want to stay around for any longer when the whispers felt like prickles at his skin.

Izuku hurried out of the lobby, hanging his head to escape the phantom looming after him.

Hiryu rushed towards him, reaching his hand outwards. “Izuku—”

But Izuku slipped out of his grasp, not wanting to hear what he had to say.

He went straight towards his room and blocked out the calling of his name behind him. But no matter how far he ran, he could feel the cold double target painted on his back in bright red.

The names plates on his and Tomura's bedroom no longer read '117' and 'Izuku'. Now it read '117' and '217'.

He had gained his mark and lost his name.

Everything was tainted with the reality of what they were expected to do raining down on him. His eyes were stretched wide as he stared around at the lavish items inside of his bedroom. All this meant nothing now, and he could see through the ploy of the luxury material to keep them pacified.

Tomura then came rushing out of the bathroom, half wet like he finished showering. He swung open the bathroom door with wide eyes, and relief washed over him at the sight of Izuku standing in the doorway.

"You survived," Tomura said in a deep exhale. "I didn't think you were going to make it. This is great." He ran his hand through his damp hair and walked up to Izuku, but Izuku took an immediate step back. Tomura froze. "Izuku?"

"We're being raised to kill people," Izuku whispered. His eyes were wide with fear and the tears inside of them were flowing freely now. "This whole time? That's all we've been learning, isn't it?"

Tomura's face fell and he pressed his lips into a thin line.

"Yes," Tomura confirmed. "That's our purpose in life."

Izuku's eyes squeezed shut.

The truth tasted like acid. *Kill*. Killing. They were killers—

He began to shake his head frantically and back away into the corner. He tried to calm himself down and began to think of violin music when his chest convulsed. However, his mind fractured like glass. In the reflection of the fragments, his warm memories of playing in the plaza with Kacchan and the cold, horrifying events of killing Sen stood out side by side.

"No," Izuku shakily whispered as his whole body began to tremble. He backed into the corner and slid down the wall. "No, no, no, no." He stared up at his older brother in hope for understanding from the only person he had. "T-Tomura, we have to get out. Th-This is bad. Killing is *bad*."

Tomura's eyes were empty. "Says who?"

"Says—"

Izuku stopped his words.

He realized he learned killing was bad from the book he *wasn't* supposed to have.

He swallowed what he was going to say, but it was too late. Tomura was already surveying him suspiciously. His big brother stepped forward menacingly and squatted down to Izuku's

level. Izuku curled into himself more, trying to steady his breathing.

“Where exactly did you learn the notion that killing was bad?” Tomura asked again. “Because it wasn’t from Mr. Compress. Or Ms. Nagant. Or Nine. Or *me*.” His eyes narrowed venomously. “So where *exactly* did you hear that?”

Izuku held his breath.

“Was it from that violinist you used to see from when you used to sneak out?” Tomura answered for him.

Izuku’s silence was enough of a confirmation.

“Whatever that man told you was wrong.” Tomura grabbed him by his jaw and forced him to look at him. “Killing is perfectly *fine*. Hurting people is *okay*. Everyone is evil to an extent and killing someone is just lessening the evil in the world.”

Izuku’s chest heaved when he realized he wasn’t sure what was the truth.

Was killing bad? Was it not?

As if he could read the conflict in Izuku’s head, Tomura continued speaking.

“Izuku. Bury every notion that you might’ve learned outside of these walls right now,” Tomura warned, digging his nails into Izuku’s skin. “If you don’t, then you’re as good as dead like the kids who didn’t survive The Cull. The only goal in your pathetic life is to *survive*. And surviving means doing as you’re *told*. If you’re told to go kill some scummy man, then so be it. Now get it the fuck together.”

Izuku’s breathing began running ragged.

He tried to calm down and the only way he knew how was to think of Kacchan. All he could see was kind Kacchan. Blond hair. Red eyes. Violin music. Romantic scenes. Their string rings. Marriage.

“Izuku—do you understand me?” Tomura snapped, angrily.

“Ye-Yes,” Izuku muttered quickly.

The memories in Izuku’s head split further the longer he tried to remain calm. Then images of Sen’s mangled body kept flashing in his mind.

Tomura was watching him carefully, looking down at him. Then slowly he hooked a finger under Izuku’s shirt collar and pulled it back, revealing his mark.

Tomura scoffed in surprise. “217?” He questioned, raising a brow. “Funny. We somehow ended up matching, little brother. Looks like you really are fated to be my mini me.”

That night Izuku could barely breathe.

Every time he closed his eyes he saw Sen. He heard the snapping of his neck and his scream. He could feel the vibrations of Himiko's crying and her deep threat to even the score.

He was in danger.

Izuku tried to do everything he could to stay calm and sleep—but it was useless. He stayed inside of his memories for as long as he could until they were no longer enough. The distant vision of Kacchan wasn't powerful enough to override the terrifying image of Sen's mangled limbs. The song of the violinist was not loud enough in his head to drown out the sound of bones snapping out of place.

All Izuku could think was to get out. Out. Out. Out.

He awoke in the dead of night and crept out of bed quietly. He checked to make sure Tomura was asleep before he secretly packed a bag while holding in his tears.

He was going to find Kacchan. He had to find Kacchan *now*. There were no other options because he couldn't stay here.

Izuku opened the door with the expert stealth he accumulated over the years.

The hallways were empty and there were caretakers patrolling casually around with large guns. Izuku concealed himself in the corners of hallways and shadows of dim lights to make his way to the staircase. He worked his way all the way down to the basement.

He disregarded all warnings he was given from Tomura about leaving.

He picked the lock to the room and went straight for the tile.

But when he tried to tip it open—it was cemented shut.

"No," Izuku whispered, all color draining from his face.

He tried again and began knocking on all the tiles on the floor. Each time he pounded his fist against the ground his desperation grew. He slammed his hands harder and harder until he was banging on the concrete holding back a scream.

A loud creak caused him to stop.

Izuku whimpered as he curled his fists on the cold ground. All his nerves went numb as he inched his head to stare over his shoulder.

Tomura walked into the tiny room and shut the door. Izuku bit his lip and tasted iron on his tongue.

"I told them I found rats," Tomura explained. He placed his hand on Izuku's shoulder and it burned with a threat. "After that, they rodent proofed the whole place. But little did they know, it was to keep one big vermin from escaping out."

“Please,” Izuku begged, his tears free falling again. He dug his fingers into the concrete as if it would crumble at his touch. “I want out. I d-don’t want to kill people and I don’t want to *die*.”

“Unfortunately, it’s only one or the other, Izuku.”

Izuku sobbed harder than he ever had.

He cried and rocked slightly in place and Tomura let him. He doesn’t know how long they stayed there but it was long enough for Izuku to grieve his freedom and the thoughts of ever finding Kacchan again.

ɯɯɯ

Now that he wasn’t a kid anymore, he was in phase two according to the caretakers.

Phase two meant learning to kill.

No one else thought this was horrible, it was only Izuku because only Izuku had read material from outside their library.

Izuku decided he needed space, and the only thing that could give him that was walking around the academy aimlessly. Sometimes if he zoned out hard enough, the white walls all seemed the same. He could momentarily pretend as if he was walking through an endless large cloud.

One particular day right before the Phase Two meeting, Izuku wound up near Ms. Nagant’s office. Kids rarely came up here, which made Izuku even more confused to find Hiryu pressing his ear against the surface of Ms. Nagant’s wooden door.

“Hiryu?” Izuku called out. “What are you doing—”

Hiryu made a silent ‘hush’ motion by putting his finger to his lips.

Izuku stilled, understanding Hiryu was doing something he wasn’t supposed to be. Izuku looked over his shoulder and saw no one and walked quietly over too. Hiryu didn’t seem to care, too focused on eavesdropping.

Izuku crouched down and pressed his ear against the door too.

“Moore,” Ms. Nagant spoke the name in a professional tone. Her octave was even, but waiver on patience and homicide. “We have a standing contract to receive one hundred children every five years, and you are *greatly* overdue. Where are they?”

“I’m sorry Kaina, this is not possible anymore,” the deep voice of a man said. There was a stretch of silence and the pace of footsteps. “Due to current internal issues I’m dealing with, I need to break our little contract.”

“And *you* know that is not possible,” Ms. Nagant bit back. “Are you going to tell that to One and Nine and expect to keep your life?”

“Maybe if they weren’t so *wasteful* with the products I would reconsider,” the man snapped. “Do you know how hard it is to bribe over one hundred mothers into giving up their children? Even more so, do you know how hard it is to find people who are willing to pay for damaged goods after you send them back to me when you deem them unworthy for your academy?”

“I’m sure you can find *someone* who will buy damaged goods, they are still goods.”

“Who on earth would want a product that is so deeply traumatized it has nightmares? You all are costing me *money* at this rate and ruining my own reputation in the underground. I will get you the next shipment when I am able to. It will not be quick and there will not be as many. But you will take what you can get.”

A long sigh from Ms. Nagant.

“A hundred children. That is the agreement,” she spoke. She was unmoving in her stance. “One is gracious enough to give you until the youngest cohort is eighteen to get the next round.”

The man scoffed.

“Did you all *finally* realize children raising children was deranged?” The man asked sarcastically. “I still remember how you all handed a bunch of seven and eight year olds toddlers and told them they were responsible for them now.”

“Our methods worked,” Nagant defended. “But potentially we can find room for improvement waiting a bit longer this time. Which means, you’re lucky enough to have room to get your act together in the meantime.”

“How *gracious* of you.”

“Of course. It’s a pleasure doing business with you, Moore. Now, if you’ll excuse me, I need to get prepped for a training session with the new Phase Twos. I’ll have my men escort you to the front door. I hope the next time I see you it’s with a hundred children in tow.”

The footsteps came close to the door and Izuku scrambled backwards.

He glanced up at Hiryu and saw something that stunned him. Hiryu’s usually warm face was blank and cold. Something lethal was flipped in his mind but Izuku could barely understand it as Hiryu slipped away from the door. The older boy rounded the corner quickly, entirely out of sight. Izuku did the same, taking the hint they heard something they weren’t supposed to.

When the door to Ms. Nagant’s office opened, Izuku carefully peered around the corner.

Out walked a man dressed in an all-white suit. He had copper hair and light brown eyes. He was dripping in gold jewelry and had rosy cheeks. He adjusted his cufflinks briefly before

walking away in the other direction, accompanied by two threatening looking men in black with guns.

When the man disappeared, Izuku focus in on what was said.

Children raising children.

He did the math: he was ten and Tomura was fifteen. Hiryu and Jin were sixteen. Ibara was fifteen. Himiko was ten. Sen had been ten.

It clicked to Izuku that this was a cycle, and it was going to *continue*. He was going to get a Little, and they would be purged through the same horrible cull as he was. Izuku didn't know if he could stomach that thought.

ᔓᔓᔓ

9 Years Until Incident

Izuku was instructed to shadow Tomura on his assignments in the outside world for the following year.

Izuku quickly learned that red folders meant killing—and that's all Tomura did was kill. He buried bodies, he framed people for murder, sometimes he even staged suicides. Every deed he did was atrocious—but he did it with an emotionless face.

Every day, Izuku watched Tomura kill person after person. He had a perfect kill record, not a single tarnish was on it unlike others in the academy who hit minor complications.

Tomura was effortless in his acts of cruelty.

For the most part, Izuku was only there to observe and help with disposal. Many times Tomura tried to encourage him to assist in killing someone before his first assignment, but Izuku shied away. He could wait.

But he also heard the gossip at home though, many other littles were helping their bigs murder. Izuku seemed to be the only one who wasn't.

Blood was a simple routine in his life now. He breathed it like air.

Over time, Tomura's ruthlessness quickly gained him the favor of Nine. Often, their head father would nod at Tomura. This was an unheard-of praise and that was enough for Izuku to fear and respect his big brother even more.

More eyes were on Izuku as a result since he was a direct reflection of Tomura. Everyone said it made sense now that Izuku killed Sen if someone as outstanding as Tomura was guiding him. Cruelty was something Izuku probably should have breathed by now.

However, it wasn't.

Izuku lacked the killer instinct his brother had but Tomura was determined to beat it into him.

The first massacre Izuku was exposed to up close was forever burned into his memory.

So far, all the previous marks had been from afar. All Tomura had to do was send bullets through a window, but now that his big brother was showing '*advanced*' behaviors, according to Ms. Nagant, Tomura was officially being given more complicated tasks.

Ones that required someone to directly jam a knife into another person's throat.

They had to dress the part. Faces fully concealed so no one could identify them. Their all-black clothing was from head to toe and on their faces were black porcelain masks. Tomura resembled a deity to Izuku like this, poised with his silver hair half down, half up in a tight bun. The black steel machetes on his back were in an X formation and the gun in his hands were purely an extension of him.

The mark's name was Yato Tamotsu.

He was insanely rich according to the red folder. He had a smug air about him with deep connections to the Tokyo underground scene through drugs. He had stepped on the Yakuza Hier's toes, Chisaki Kai, though by poaching territory that wasn't his. From what Izuku overheard during the debriefing with Ms. Nagant, Chisaki Kai was someone the academy always did business with.

The Academy's roots in Tokyo helped the Yakuza keep their grip on the city. In exchange, the Yakuza made sure the Academy could do what they did peacefully without too many eyes on them. Sometimes the Yakuza even help police the Vipers if someone was to go rouge and escape.

It was a toxic, symbiotic relationship that helped keep the underground flowing.

Anyone that crossed Chisaki was likely to be put down by a Viper. It was well known in the whispers in the shadows.

Tomura and Izuku were dispatched to Yato's mansion where he was having a party. Flickering disco lights were shining everywhere as people ran around in their swimsuits but there was no pool. A regular Tuesday night for someone as rich in blood money as Yato.

The duo of Vipers barged into the mansion, and Tomura didn't hesitate to fire his rifle immediately.

Screams erupted and the whole scene was tossed into pure chaos. Dark crimson blood splattered like paint on the walls and decorated the lavish carpet. Tomura swiftly sunk a bullet in everyone's skull who attempted to flee while Izuku meekly covered for him near the exit in case anyone attempted to escape.

But he was barely useful, Tomura shot everyone down in record timing.

All the screams reminded Izuku of being trapped in the underworld. One by one, every cry was a soul Tomura collected with pride. Silence replaced the chaos, and a chill ran down Izuku's spine. He looked around, and no one had escaped. Izuku felt nauseous as he walked behind his brother into the bloodied room. He counted the bodies as he followed Tomura's lead.

One. Two. Four. Six.

It ended up being twelve.

Tomura had slain twelve people in under a minute.

Izuku watched carefully how Tomura stalked up to the mark cowering in the corner. He had somehow saved Yato Tamotsu for last, effectively making him witness the death of all his friends in a mere blink of an eye.

The poor man was sobbing and trembling.

"Pl-Please! Spare me!" The man gasped, jarred at the sight of all the bodies beneath Tomura's feet. Izuku's heart clutched. He had never heard anyone beg for their life before. "I-I have a family! I am a good man I swear!"

Tomura tilted his head, face concealed with the porcelain mask that now had blood splatters. "I doubt that."

"I-I also have a young daughter, who is struggling with *leukemia*, she needs me," the man continued.

Izuku sucked in a ragged breath when he painted a picture of Yato Tamotsu's family. He could envision the children grieving their father, and even see the young girl dying from lack of proper medical treatment.

"Please. Please. *D-Don't kill me.*"

Izuku turned his head away when Tomura reached for one of his machetes off his back. He screwed his eyes shut when the begging became too much and covered his ears. He braced himself for Tomura's brutality—but nothing ever came.

Izuku's heart slowed down. He peaked his eye open and gazed at the two in front of him.

Yato Tamotsu was looking confused as well.

Tomura's head was turned towards him.

"Do you think I should spare him?" Tomura asked.

Izuku's eyes widened, and he glanced around, making sure that he was the only living person Tomura was speaking to. All he found around him were dead bodies, which baffled him even further.

“Wh-What? Are you asking me?” Izuku clarified.

“Yes.” Tomura lifted the porcelain mask off his face, revealing a tired expression. He cut his blood-colored eyes towards Izuku. “Do you think we should let him go?”

Izuku wearily glanced towards the cowering man on the floor. His eyes and heart softened as he thought about what he had said, and the image of the family in his mind.

“Y-Yes,” Izuku whispered. Yato Tamotsu’s shoulders tightened, and his eyes sparked with hope. “He has a family, right? We should let him live so he can perform his duty towards them.”

Tomura’s facial muscles didn’t move.

“Okay,” Tomura agreed. He stepped aside swiftly, surprising Izuku further. “Pick him up off the ground and we can transport him somewhere safe.”

“Really?”

“Really.” Tomura put his machete back into its holster and jutted his chin towards the mark. “Hurry before I change my mind. I’ll go stage it like he escaped.”

Izuku snapped his own mask off his face and nearly ran to the crying man. Yato Tamotsu was terrified but happy and Izuku’s chest swelled with joy too. Maybe Tomura wasn’t as cut off from his humanity like Izuku originally thought. Maybe Tomura was like him even—caring, deep inside for others so much it pained him.

Izuku picked up the crying man from the ground, and Yato Tamotsu leaned into him due to his gunshot injury. Tomura had shattered his kneecaps with two precise bullets but at least he still had his life.

“Thank you,” Tamotsu Yato whispered, he stared at Izuku thankful and gripped onto him tightly. “You don’t know how much this means to me—”

A deafening gunshot hit Izuku’s ears at the same time he witnessed, eyes wide, Tomura blow the man’s brains out at a blinding speed.

Izuku stopped breathing as his face was coated in blood.

Yato Tamotsu’s eyes popped and the heavy body dropped in an instant. Izuku was unwillingly dragged down too by the weight, falling directly on top of the mangled body.

Izuku was so stunned, he couldn’t process it right away. Blood seeped through his pants, into the cracks of his fingers and his lungs began tightening from not inhaling. He began shaking, playing over and over again the way the man’s head was blown open right in front of his eyes.

Izuku gasped for air when he needed oxygen, and his face was nearly purple.

“He didn’t have a family,” Tomura explained coldly while lowering his gun. “It was in the folder that he’s a pathological *liar*. If you’re going to speak to the marks, at least read the details all the way. Otherwise, you risk being manipulated, like you were here.”

Izuku couldn’t stop trembling.

He squeezed his eyes shut and let go of the dead body.

“You’re *weak*, Izuku,” Tomura hissed in disgust. “You’re lucky you have me as your Big and not someone else who would’ve killed you for the type of shit you just pulled. Now help me clean up this mess before you piss me off further.”

Tomura stormed off and began finishing their assignment.

When Izuku gained the strength to glance around, everything in the mansion was dressed in dark, scarlet blood—including himself. Tomura didn’t miss a beat while he staged it like a drug deal gone wrong. He planted evidence to lead the police in the wrong direction with a straight face and clear conscious.

Izuku stared down at the dead body of Yato Tamotsu. He studied the way the skull was blown up, dripping blood and felt numb to it. Maybe he was more desensitized to murder than he realized. Or maybe he felt a tiny bit of disgust and disappointment in himself.

The man had lied to try to save his life—and Izuku was stupid enough to believe him.

Izuku curled his fists, frustrated.

After the assignment, Izuku didn’t speak at all. He let Tomura lead him around when they made their way back to their home, he couldn’t wash away the feeling of being covered in blood.

“Nine picked out a code name for me by the way,” Tomura told him that night. He was sharpening his blade calmly, making sure it was deadly for their next assignment. “He’s never done that for anyone before. I guess that means I’m in his good graces so don’t mess this up for me.”

“What is the name?” Izuku asked blankly.

“Horned Viper.”

Immediately, the image his brother with horns like a demon filled his mind. He could see the horns curl, and they would probably be pitch black to match his heart.

Izuku nodded. “That suits you.”

ɯɯɯ

8 Years Until Incident

When Izuku was twelve he learned what the words ‘adopted’ and ‘kidnaped’ meant.

He had found out through stealing a dictionary from the house of one-man Tomura killed. As Izuku was dissolving the body in an acid bath, he noticed the book on a tiny nightstand.

He tucked it in his backpack and brought it back home with him.

That night, when Tomura was asleep, Izuku cracked open his romance novel. He finally filled in all the gaps with the words he didn't know.

He went highlighted word by highlighted word and pieced everything together.

The world he was able to read now in the novel was so much more enriched. It was vibrant and lush. But worst of all, it was even nicer than he thought.

The family in this book was described to be something loving and warm. They embraced each other and were nice to one another. Izuku teared up as he comprehended the world written in this book for the first time because he pieced together what a kidnapping was.

The woman in the novel had been kidnapped, stolen away from her family by evil people. They forced her to do work that she didn't want to do. They even fully separated her from people who loved her. Her family and husband were in deep despair, and that's when her husband said he would go find her and he embarked on his epic journey to rescue his love.

It was that night when Izuku came to the only conclusion that made sense for his life too—he had to have been stolen. Somewhere out there was a family like this waiting on him, one where they hugged and kissed each other.



7 Years Until Incident

It was July 15th and Izuku had officially turned thirteen this morning.

He was feeling higher levels of bitterness coursing in his system when he awoke that day. All he could think about was how he wasn't meant to have this type of life. He should be having birthday parties like the ones in the book, or happy dinners with people who loved him. He shouldn't be here—and he was upset about it.

Unfortunately, this upset rolled over into Tomura's assignments.

Part of Izuku's job as phase two was to make sure the mark was dead. He never buried a body without double checking—but today he had simply put the man in the ground. Then that came back to bite them both in the ass, literally. The man somehow clawed his way out and tackled Tomura to the ground.

He had seized one of Tomura's machetes and gashed him directly from his lip to his eye, making him scream. Then in the next split second, Tomura shot the man in the throat. Blood sprayed everywhere and leaked down Tomura's once perfect face. Izuku winced when he saw the damage. Tomura's eye was in dire need of medical attention, and they had to go to the infirmary immediately when returning home.

Now, Tomura was pissed at him.

“What is with you lately?” Tomura snapped when they got into their room. “Do you need more punishment? Because I can go get a goddamn belt and beat the shit out of you if that’s what it takes to make you act right.”

“I’m fine,” Izuku said from his gritted teeth. He huffed in irritation as he took off his gear and sloppily tossed it to the side of the room. “I’m always *fine*.”

“Don’t give me that,” Tomura hissed. He marched up to Izuku and got directly in his face. Up close, Izuku could see the new wound on Tomura’s face throb. “I don’t need the fucking attitude from you after you nearly got my eye cut out. Now what’s with you?”

Izuku winced, feeling a tiny bit guilty for the gash across Tomura’s face. “Nothing is wrong.”

“You’re a terrible liar,” Tomura pointed out. He rolled his eyes and turned around. “When you’re done throwing your *tantrum* let me know. We have another assignment tomorrow that I need to debrief you on.”

“I’m not going,” Izuku whispered under his breath.

Tomura stopped walking and glared over his shoulder. “What did you say?”

“I said I’m not going,” Izuku repeated, a lot more forceful. “I’m not doing this anymore.”

“We’ve been over this, you have only two options—”

“—Kill or be killed. *I know*,” Izuku snapped. “That’s all you ever do is remind me how fast our lives can go away in the blink of an eye.”

“I remind you of that every day because you’re too *stupid* to absorb what I am saying,” Tomura growled. “With the way you act, I think I am the only one between the two of us who values your life.”

“…I don’t want to hurt people anymore.” Izuku lowered his head. “Please.”

“This shit again?” Tomura groaned tiredly. “You’re going to have your first assignment in a week, so you better learn to want to hurt people.”

“But not all people are bad!” Izuku finally fought back. “There’s good people in the world and I don’t want to accidentally hurt a good person! You can’t tell who is good or bad and that’s why killing is wrong. Wh-What if we went to the police and—”

“—Keep your voice down,” Tomura seethed. He grabbed Izuku by the arm and slammed him against the wall. “Do you really think people out there give a fuck about you?” Tomura’s eyes turned frigid and intensified. “You are the same as the rest of us, discarded into the goddamn trash. You should be kissing the ground Nine and One walk on for taking you in.”

“We were *kidnapped*,” Izuku hissed. He glared at Tomura, not hearing a word he was saying. “We don’t owe them shit for taking us away from our real families!”

The rage in Tomura's eyes slowly diminished. He cocked his head at Izuku.

"Kidnapped? Is that what you think happened to us?"

"Yes," Izuku responded sourly. "We had to be kidnapped. It all adds up that—th-that's the only answer. I bet all of our families are out there waiting for us to come back home while we're stuck here. That's why they don't let us go outside because they know someone is looking for us."

Tomura let out a sharp, dry chuckle. "You haven't been listening to a single thing Mr. Compress teaches us about human nature, have you?"

His brother took a large step back and let him go.

Tomura then walked over to his dresser that he always kept locked up.

The sudden switch in his brother's demeanor was like whiplash. Izuku stared on, confused as Tomura unlocked the dresser with a key on a necklace around his neck. He watched Tomura pull out a small file organizer. He thumbed through a bunch of beige folders before pulling out one and unclipping specific papers inside. He neatly placed it back where he got it from and locked his dresser tight.

His eyes turned on Izuku and walked up to him with the paper in hand.

"I may be cruel, but I do not lie to you," Tomura spat. "When I say that I am the *only* one who cares about you—that is not a lie. But despite what I have said, do you really think there's someone else out there who cares about you besides *me*?" Tomura asked carefully.

Izuku knew it was a trick question—but he was confident in his answer. "Of course. My real parents love me, and I know they are looking for me, just like yours are."

The paper was whipped in front of him with a picture.

"This is your birth mother," Tomura explained with no inflection. "Her name is Midoriya Inko. She lives right here in Tokyo, and she's been going by a new alias of Nakashima Yoko."

Izuku's heart skipped a beat.

He took the paper, like it was a long-lost treasure. He stared at it wondering if this was some sort of trick and turned it over but only saw the tiny bits of information. He looked at her photo and she seemed so kind. She was smiling. She had a dimple like him. Green hair like him. Even her eyes were green—like his. Izuku smiled a bit, realizing he looked identical to her. His mind filled in the blanks of having a normal life at his fingertips.

This was too good to be true.

"Wh-Why are you giving this to me?" Izuku muttered.

“Think of it as a birthday present.” Tomura waved his hand. “Go see her and tell her who you are, *Midoriya* Izuku.”

“And how am I supposed to go see her if I’m trapped in this place?”

“You have your mark now,” Tomura said flippantly. He picked the caked blood from under his nails and didn’t bother to look up at Izuku. “You have more free range than you did before, I forgot to tell you. You’re allowed to wander in the city as long as you’re back by check in.”

This time Izuku was baffled. “How come now?”

“Because it’s easier to find you.” Tomura tapped his collar bone to remind Izuku of his mark. “So, go to her. I’m sure she’ll take you in. Check out at the front door.”

Izuku stepped backwards with the paper in his hand.

He looked at the address on the sheet of paper and knew exactly where that was. His heart hammered over and over with various emotions.

“…You’re letting me leave?” Izuku whispered, confused.

“I am,” Tomura said. He curled his upper lip. “Be with your *real* family.”

Izuku stayed frozen as Tomura packed his backpack for him. His brother angrily shoved clothes, snacks, and water inside. He even packed tooth paste and other toiletries that Izuku might need if he was going to go away for a while. Sadness panged in Izuku’s chest at the sight of his brother practically shoving him out of the door.

Why did he feel so sad about this?

Before he could understand it, his brother shoved the backpack against his chest with an ugly scowl.

“Happy birthday, Izuku.”

ᔓᔓᔓ

Getting out was as easy as Tomura said it was.

He checked out at the front door, signed his name and put his number down. The secretary, Yui, smiled at him, and Izuku noticed her mark as well. The number 93 was behind her ear as she gave Izuku information on where he could and could not go.

“As a phase two, you have to stay within the red boundary,” Yui said softly.

She traced the map of Japan and showed him his limits. Izuku noted how Phase Three’s like Tomura and Jin were allowed to wander pretty much all over. Phase ones were restricted only to the compound. It was organized out with the more trust one gained through their family, the more freedom they earned.

“Have a fun off day!” Yui chimed.

Izuku took the map of Tokyo that was given to him and walked through the doors.

Then within a second, he hissed slightly when a tingle in his thigh hummed. It was subtle, and he assumed it to be a pinched nerve of sorts he hadn’t tended to correctly.

He shook it off and continued his walk around the busy city.

It was a lovely summer day, and his heart was pounding as he passed by the people in the busy streets of Tokyo. The flashing neon lights were terribly bright, and his large eyes were taking in everything. Every smile. Every laugh. It was all the things he had read about being so wonderful and he was on his way to meet someone who might gaze at him that way too.

Izuku clutched the paper to his beating heart, feeling conflicted.

He didn’t want to leave Tomura fully, but that guilt was overshadowed when his imagination filled up with scenarios from his romance novel. He could see himself being the one kidnapped and his parents crying over him. He knew they were reaching out for him and trying with all their power to find him.

Then as Izuku was walking through the streets of Tokyo, he saw soft blond hair in the corner of his eye in the crowd.

A chaotic hurricane of emotion was set off inside of him.

Izuku stopped walking and snapped his head to track the strangely familiar sight. He stared with wide eyes behind him to see a tall figure pushing through the crowd in the opposite direction as if upset. The texture of the hair was spiked, and it made Izuku’s heart skip a beat. It looked just like—

“Kacchan?” Izuku called, but he was too far away.

He walked forward, as if caught in a trance. He lightly jogged to the person, holding out his hand.

But too distracted, Izuku bumped directly into another man. He hissed and dropped the paper of his mother’s information on the ground. The man he had knocked over stumbled and fumbled his phone and glared at Izuku.

Izuku muttered a clumsy apology that wasn’t accepted. He winced at the choice words that were showered upon him as the unkind man shoved past him. Izuku quickly bent down and gathered up the paper of his mother’s information before someone stepped on it. In return, his finger was crushed by a businessman who was walking too quickly.

Izuku yelped, pulled his hand back, and glared up at the businessman who was already halfway gone.

By the time Izuku stood up again, the head of blond hair was nowhere to be found.

He gazed around, confused. *Was that real?*

The paper in his hand rustled with the summer wind. It caught his attention and reminded him of the very reason he was out and about.

Focus, Izuku.

Izuku took a deep breath and began walking the other direction.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku walked up slowly towards the woman who was humming happily in the garden. She was bent down, tending to a small bush in her yard. Her silky hair was pulled back into an elegant bun and she was dressed in comfortable summer clothes.

Izuku gazed at her in amazement and quietly walked up to the house.

“E-Excuse me?” Izuku spoke in a soft voice.

His mother turned towards him curiously, then froze upon seeing him. Her green eyes widened and then she slowly stood upright. She cocked her head at him like she had seen a phantom from the past.

“Are you Midoriya Inko?” Izuku asked with a welcoming smile.

“I don’t know who Midoriya Inko is,” his mother quickly said. “I’m sorry you have the wrong person. Now, please excuse me. I have dinner going in the oven.”

She turned around in haste and rushed towards the stairs of her home. She reached the handle of the door and Izuku panicked.

“M-My name is Izuku!” Izuku shouted. He imagined how it would go in his head, seeing her smile and rush towards him when she recognized who he was. “M-Midoriya Izuku. I was born on July 15th, thirteen years ago.”

Her ankles were gripped by his words.

Izuku’s heart hammered slowly when she turned around.

This time there was deep recognition in her eyes and Izuku awaited the hug that he thought he would receive. But he got nothing in exchange and his skin was left feeling cold. Inko turned around and her eyes were ten times more fearful while staring at him.

“I think you’re my mom,” Izuku whispered. He wrung his hands, feeling awkward.

Inko’s eyes skirted around. “How did you find me?”

“I—I was given your address and photo,” Izuku explained eagerly. He pulled out the folded paper with shaky hands and showed it to her. She took it from him and slowly her face

became shadowed in a dark cloud upon seeing the information. “I am your biological son. I was hoping we could reconnect?”

“I—” Inko exhaled gently. She handed back the paper to him shamefully. “This is…This is. Ah. Why don’t you come in? I can make some tea for you.”

Izuku perked up, smiling with his heart hammering.



The inside of his mother’s house was gorgeous.

It was painted a welcoming yellow color on the walls, warm, and smelled of oranges. The TV was running the news, and the whole house was big enough for a family of four. Izuku studied the portraits on the walls closely as his mother walked into the kitchen to make tea.

It was silent between them, and he could feel her look at him several times within their quietness.

Izuku smiled at her and she wearily smiled back.

All around on the walls were family photos of his mother with a man with all black hair. They had a baby, from what it seemed. Next to these family pictures were photographs of the baby smiling and Izuku imagined himself in these portraits soon.

Inko brought out the tea and gestured Izuku over to the wooden table politely. Izuku sat down across from her. He stared at the pictures, particularly the man’s face.

“Is that your husband?” Izuku asked with a smile.

“Yes. I’m married.” Inko held up her hand to show the diamond ring on her finger. “He’s at work currently.”

Izuku smiled gingerly. He took a small sip of the tea to steady himself when his nerves rattled. He wanted to ask if that man was his father but didn’t exactly know how.

“Izuku,” Inko started. She cleared her throat and leaned forward. “How did you find that information? It was supposed to be under a very careful lock and key. No one should be able to know about my old identity.”

Izuku blinked a couple of times, knocked out of his daydreams.

“…I was given it as a birthday gift,” Izuku explained vaguely. He didn’t want to tell her fully he was being trained to be a murderer and was given the information in a fight between him and his also kidnapped brother. “I was told I could come find you.”

“I see.” Inko’s fingers tapped the table in deep thought. “Did Koizumi give it to you?”

Izuku wrinkled his nose. “Who is Koizumi?”

“He’s the man who promised me that I could start over,” Inko explained. She then fiddled with her thumbs. “He…He told me I could escape from the life I was trapped in if I…if I gave him you in exchange for money and a new identity.”

Izuku stopped drinking his tea.

He placed down the porcelain cup and the visions of family fractured slightly.

“You sold me?” Izuku clarified.

“I’m sorry,” Inko apologized in a soft tone. “Koizumi promised me you would be taken somewhere that would love you more than I could. He said something about families who wanted toddlers but didn’t want to go the route of adoption due to complications within the government. I thought that would be the best option for both of us. It was my only option at the time to ensure I could start over. I hope you can forgive me.”

Izuku tried to fend off the disgust that clung to his skin. It crawled like a thousand spiders, and nested into him—but he plucked it out before the venom could be injected. He delicately picked up his fragmented smile and pieced it back together. Then he leaned in, drenched in desperation.

Inko leaned backwards.

“I forgive you,” Izuku whispered, trying even to fool himself. “It clearly was a poor decision made at the time. You have your new life like you wanted, and I want to know you. I was hoping that…that maybe we could get to know each other?”

Izuku reached out, touched her hand and she yanked it away. It might as well have been a slap.

Inko furiously shook her head and clutched her hand to her chest. She was jittering like there was some sort of monster keeping her from receiving Izuku’s affection.

“No. You don’t understand,” Inko whispered. “Whether there was money or not I would have still given you up, Izuku. I-I can’t love you like you need me to.”

The temperature in the room dropped.

Izuku’s breathing slowed. “Wh-Why not?”

A broken gaze was his only answer at first. Everything in Inko’s eyes was swallowed in despair and she was shaking her head softly, as if begging Izuku to drop the subject. But Izuku couldn’t. He clung harder to those daydreams of a family he had painted inside of his mind and pressed forward.

“Please,” Izuku begged. “I-I need to know.”

“Don’t do this to yourself and don’t make me say it. This is cruel to both of us.”

Izuku’s face twisted. “*Tell me*.”

“Because you have his freckles,” Inko confessed through clenched teeth.

Izuku touched his face as if trying to understand. “Who?”

“Your biological father,” Inko continued. She hung her head and turned her eyes away from him. “You—You look like me, but you have *that* feature of his. He hurt me in one of the worst possible ways and you were a product of it. Seeing his freckles on your face that is so close to mine, hurts me too much and I could barely look at you when you were born.”

Inko wiped a single tear from her face.

“I-I tried taking care of you,” Inko confessed. “I did. I tried my *best* for two years. B-But I couldn’t do it. I was struggling and every day you grew more and more to resemble him. His freckles on your face got darker and multiplied. Then your hair curled in the same way as his —I felt sick looking at you and I hated myself for it. Even now, sitting across from you hurts me in the same way it did back then.”

Izuku’s hands were trembling as he touched his own cheek.

The sound of a baby crying from upstairs broke the moment.

Inko quickly stood up from her chair, head still turned away from him. She scrambled and picked up the baby monitor, leaving Izuku there alone at the table.

Izuku’s leg began jittering and his eyes stung.

Everything was wrong. This was wrong. Wrong. Wrong. Wrong.

Tears too big for his own heart swelled in his eyes. He resisted crying as he gazed around at the pictures on the wall of the perfect family that he thought he would be a part of. He marveled at how joyous his mother seemed. Everything inside the home was perfect and neat.

But every vision of the future Izuku had slowly burned in his head, leaving behind seared dreams.

When Inko came downstairs, she was cradling a crying child in her arms. The baby stared back at him with innocent eyes and straight, jet black hair. Izuku’s heart took a hit when he could see their resemblance ever so slightly. Green eyes and olive skin. Only difference was their hair, and his half-brother didn’t have freckles.

“Please,” Izuku pleaded. “P-Please. I-I’m sorry for looking like him b-but I need help getting away from where I’m at. I-I think I’m in danger and I need *help*.”

Inko shook her head mournfully. “I’m sorry, Izuku. But I can’t help you. I have a family that I love and need to make sure is safe, I can’t risk any trouble. Especially if you’re still tied to Koizumi. You’re on your own.”

Izuku tightened his jaw, trying to hold it together. He looked at the photographs on the wall and then back to the person he wanted to call mother.

“Then can you tell me who my father is?” Izuku tried. Maybe. Just maybe he had someone else—

“He’s not an option,” Inko whispered. “You’re better off not knowing who he is.”

Izuku’s heart stopped. Inko averted her eyes as the final blow was laid.

“Go home to wherever you’re from, Izuku. Please don’t come back here.”

ᔓᔓᔓ

Broken.

Izuku had always known that word to apply to bones. Or things.

He knew it was something Tomura caused and a type of destruction that eventually could be fixed. But Izuku never knew that it could apply to something not visible to his eye. He had read in his book about a ‘broken heart’ and never grasped the concept.

Until now.

There was something in his chest that was hurting. Like a hand was squeezing his pounding heart unkindly every second. It restricted his breathing, his vision, his emotions and squeezed and squeezed and squeezed until he nearly collapsed on the sidewalk. There was a void in his chest that swallowed him whole when he walked out of his mother’s—

No. Not *his* mother.

Inko. She was only Inko.

There was a void in his chest that swallowed him whole when he walked out of Inko’s house.

Izuku quietly cried as he roamed the streets. People were staring at him, probably confused why such a young teen was sobbing by himself. Izuku had his head down, and hands clutching at his shirt, directly above his heart. Izuku bit his lip until it bled, trying to stop his emotions from pouring out but he couldn’t.

He couldn’t stop because she didn’t want him. She never did and she never would.

She abandoned him.

Izuku wept until he stumbled into an alley. He hiccupped as he placed his head on the wall. Why? Why, why, why was he cursed like this? He hit his fist against the brittle brick, and he crouched low to sob to himself.

He peered up angrily at the crowds that passed by the alley. They basked in the neon light while he hid in the shadows.

All the fantasies in his head incinerated into nothing. He would never be a part of such a life, would he? Just as the sourness in his heart spread to his mind, out the corner of his eye he

saw a vague figure of a blond boy.

Izuku froze, tears stopping.

“Kacchan?” Izuku whispered, slightly dazed.

He scrambled upright, and desperation latched on to him tightly.

Kacchan would want him. *They could still run away together*.

Izuku tracked the head of blond spikes in the crowd that was quickly walking away. His breath caught as he pushed through the pain in his chest.

He ran.

He chased the blond spikes in front of him like it was his last rope of hope. An ugly sob wrecked its way through him as he shoved through the never-ending sea of people. Men and women alike yelled at him, confused and offended by his roughness. Izuku didn’t care though. When he reached the blond boy, he forcefully turned around the figure by their arm, and light brown eyes greeted him.

Brown. Not red.

Izuku’s face fell and the random boy stared at him in fear.

Suddenly, both a mother and father stepped out of the blur of faces. They roughly pushed Izuku backwards for touching their son.

“What’s wrong with you?!” The father criticized. “Did anyone teach you any manners, why are you scaring my son like this?”

Izuku couldn’t find any words.

The blond boy with brown eyes looked terrified of him. Izuku wearily stared down at his hands and his vision pulsed with an oncoming headache. He looked around and there were so many eyes judging him. They were looking upon the scene with their noses turned up. Even the family in front of him were yelling words Izuku couldn’t hear past the white noise blaring in his ears.

In the pulsing headache, Izuku could see a vision of Kacchan smiling at him inside of the old church.

A terrible feeling of hope clutched him again.

Izuku stumbled back and whispered a weak apology. He turned on his heels and ran to the last place he could think of for someone who might love him. He pushed through the crowds, running against time. Or something. Or even running away from himself—his heart was pounding with all its broken pieces as he ran.

He found his way to the plaza. Upon arrival, Izuku stopped in shock.

It had changed so much, and he hadn't even noticed being trapped inside his home. All around, it was clean and brand new. Commercialized to hell and back. There were no homeless people gathered and blinding neon lights were staring back at him.

The fountain in the center was working, overflowing with clean water. Random jewelry stores had been installed and pop music he never heard played overhead. Izuku staggered as he walked, trying to comprehend.

The cracked statue of the angel was gone—and so was the violinist.

Izuku forced his feet to move.

He walked down a pathway that seemed to be the only thing left untouched. It was cracked and broken and progressively grew more fractured the further he walked. At the very end he found the abandoned church, still leaning and withstanding the test of time.

Izuku hurried to their old entrance and his heart stopped.

It was broken open, like someone had kicked it.

Izuku fluidly eased inside. He stumbled in, and it was exactly how he remembered it. Izuku wiped his tears as he looked around the vast church. Some vines had grown inside, and more wood was rotting under the wear of age. Izuku followed his heart strings as they led him to the one place he felt comfort.

He didn't think anyone would be there. He expected it to be as untouched as it was the last time he came and left that note.

However, when he arrived it looked recently disturbed.

Izuku's eyes widened, and his heart squeezed so hard he nearly lost all his breath.

His note was gone, and so was Kacchan's favorite All Might Action figure. The pillow had been dusted off like someone had laid there, and there were handprints in the dust everywhere.

Izuku whirled around, wildly. He sprang into action, frantic to find his missing half.

"Kacchan? Kacchan!" Izuku screamed at the top of his lungs.

He called the nickname over and over inside of the abandoned building, chasing the visual of his childhood.

He cried with a convulsing chest as he could see the imagery of young him and Kacchan playing tag all over the dust covered church. He cried when he could see them in the shower area as he scrubbed him clean. He cried when he realized the building was in fact empty. All that remained were the broken memories inside of his head.

Izuku fell to his knees underneath the glittering reflections from the stained glass. He pushed his palms into his eyes trying to beg the tears to stop but they only kept coming.

When he put his hands in his lap, he saw the final visual that changed him.

He could see the memory of young Kacchan hugging him in front of the altar. His younger self hugged him back and their makeshift rings were tightly wrapped around their fingers.

“Why did you leave me too, Kacchan?” Izuku whispered, broken.

ᔓᔓᔓ

He had spent an hour staring around the church and wandering the city of Tokyo trying to figure out where to go. But every time he tried to take a step to run away, he felt the tether of awful words pounding into his consciousness. Each one was like a sledgehammer to his confidence and will.

You are weak.

You are useless.

You have no meaning.

Izuku gritted his teeth when it felt like the phrases were strangling him.

At 22:22, Izuku willingly walked back to his home. His face was swollen from crying, and his eyes were glazed over. He was depleted of everything inside of him besides the sting of bitterness. In the end, his romance book was wrong, and it was full of lies.

He signed his name back in, and Yui didn’t even seem phased by his disgruntled appearance. Izuku quietly walked back to his room holding the straps of his backpack. His head stayed down and he could feel the mark on his body like it was written on his bone. He swiped into his room and sitting there reading a book was Tomura.

His brother looked up at him with smugness.

“Did your real mommy turn out to love you?” Tomura asked, twisting the wound. “You have to tell me all about your *amazing* adventure with her.”

Izuku stared at him through his bloodshot eyes as it clicked together. His nostrils flared. For the first time in Izuku’s life, he felt rage. Pure, unbridle rage for all his broken dreams.

“You knew,” Izuku seethed. He dropped his backpack on the ground and calmly walked up to Tomura. “You knew this whole time and you still sent me there.”

“Of course I did.” Tomura tilted his head and his silver hair leaned with him. “I wanted you to see up close how unloved you are by the world, *little brother*.”

Izuku snapped.

All the built-up emotions in his chest clashed together and he lashed out on the one person who had shattered his reality.

Izuku screamed as he lunged forward, catching Tomura off guard.

His brother's eyes widened, and he caught Izuku's fist before it could connect with his face. But Izuku wanted Tomura to feel the same kind of pain he felt. He almost wanted him dead. Quickly, Izuku threw his other fist, connecting his knuckles into Tomura's cheekbones. It was then Tomura finally acted and slammed their heads together.

But no physical pain could match the throbbing hurt in Izuku's heart.

They tossed back and forth, and Izuku decided he was going for the kill. Tomura always hurt him so much. He took away everything and rubbed it in his face when he was supposed to love him too—but he never did.

In the midst of their fighting, they broke everything in their path. The mirror, the vase, and the lamp were all victims to their storm. Izuku finally used all his skills, not holding back. He grabbed the blade out of Tomura's back pocket after twisting around in an aerobic combo. His brother's eyes widened when Izuku threw off the cover from the weapon, metal singing with his motion.

Izuku went for Tomura's jugular.

He missed—by a fraction. He shallowly cut directly above his brother's pulse and was livid he didn't get it deeper.

Somehow, in the face of near death, Tomura grinned.

"There's that killer instinct—*finally*," Tomura bellowed, sounding beyond gratified.

His eerie chuckle bounced off all the walls as Izuku kept attacking him. Izuku moved impossibly quick and skilled, finally showing the full fruition of his upbringing. Tomura was just as skilled, if not more, however. He fluidly blocked every deadly blow that tried to sink into his skin with a shimmer of glee. They moved around gracefully, like the deadly vipers they were meant to be.

"That's it, Izuku," Tomura encouraged. "Harness all of that raw pain."

Izuku swung and missed. He cried and gritted his teeth as his emotions intensified.

"Faster," Tomura hissed.

Izuku sliced faster.

"More precise," Tomura lectured.

And Izuku aimed more precisely.

"C'mon. You're going to have to try a lot harder than that if you want to kill me."

"Shut up!" Izuku screamed. He jabbed the blade straight towards Tomura's throat. "Just shut up!"

The tip of the blade touched Tomura's Adam's apple—and then his wrists were seized. Izuku's vision flipped as his arm twisted behind his back quicker than he could comprehend. He was shoved, belly down, on the ground with a knee on his back.

Tomura's strong hands grabbed Izuku's elbows and yanked his arms backwards, forcing the younger boy to scream in pain. Izuku thrashed on the ground in resistance. Hurt, anger, and sadness danced inside of him in the worst synchronization as he tried to get up to put a stab wound in his brother. But the knee in his back pressed harder.

Tomura leaned all his weight on him until Izuku was struggling to even breathe.

"Do you understand what I have been saying about how awful humans are now?" Tomura jeered. "Do you finally *get it*?"

Izuku shook his head, attempting to stop his flow of tears.

Tomura twisted Izuku's arms, restraining him from moving as he spoke.

"Anyone on the street would *never* have known your mother sold her first born for a second shot at life," Tomura whispered the truth like poison dripping in his ear. "Someone would see her pushing that new baby carriage and think she's a normal goddamn citizen who is untainted. Same for my bastard father. Ibara's. Aoyama's. Hiryu's. Himiko's. Jin's. Even *Sen's*."

Izuku gritted his teeth, and his struggling became less.

"We don't know anything about anyone we're going to be tasked to kill," Tomura then spoke a bit softer. "But this proves everyone has skeletons in their closet. No matter how *good* they seem. Everyone is worthy of death to some degree therefore we don't have to know everything about every person we're asked to execute. We only have to be the bullet to the gun."

Izuku stopped struggling.

He went limp in his brother's hold and cried into the carpeted floor.

All of Izuku's dreams of love and family were officially shattered.

"…Sh-She never wanted me," Izuku rasped hoarsely. He tucked his head into the floor to hide his despair. "N-No one ever wanted me…this wh-whole time. Sh-She said she couldn't lo-love me, Tomura. She couldn't—because of how I *looked*. I-I can't even control that."

His brother let him cry.

There were no more lectures, and Izuku let out the last bit of his grief. The hands restraining him eased up as he sobbed and then something Izuku never expected to happen, did.

Tomura turned Izuku over on his back. Izuku kept his eyes screwed shut, too embarrassed and ashamed. Snot was running down his face and his mind was wrecked like someone had fully demolished all of his thoughts.

“No one cares about me,” Izuku cried.

Tomura exhaled roughly and sat back on his hunches. His empty eyes filled up with pity briefly. He pulled Izuku into his arms and gently hugged him.

Izuku clung back, without hesitation.

He cried into Tomura’s shirt and calloused fingers raked through his hair. The touch comforted him as his crying turned from sobbing to softly weeping.

“I care about you, Izuku,” Tomura muttered. “I’m the only one who does. Which is why I try so hard for you to understand what our purpose is. Do what you have to do to survive, nothing else.”

Izuku took those words to heart.

He only had to survive, and Tomura was the only person who cared about him.

They laid there, his brother giving him an inch of the mercy he somehow had left. Tomura let Izuku cry into his chest for however long he needed as they sat on the floor. Eventually, Tomura shifted them to a more comfortable position. He leaned against the side of the bed and motioned for Izuku to come sit next to him. Izuku eagerly took the opportunity, knowing this would probably be the last time he was afforded physical comfort.

Izuku hugged into Tomura’s side and his brother hugged him back.

After an hour, a knock on their door came before it was forced open. Izuku peaked up and he could see both Nine and Ms. Nagant there. Izuku flinched, trying to let go of his brother. Hugging was *bad*. Worth ten hits, exactly.

However, when Izuku tried to reel back, Tomura’s arms locked him in place. Izuku tried to see Tomura’s face but his brother quietly took his head and pushed it into the crook of his neck. Izuku was confused but went along with it.

“Is everything okay?” Nine asked wearily. “Someone walked by and heard fighting.”

“Yes, we’re fine,” Tomura said tiredly. He held Izuku in his arms tighter. “We had a training session.”

“Wait. Are you hugging and is he *crying*?” Ms. Nagant asked, revolted. Izuku stiffened. He pushed his face further into Tomura and clung harder. He didn’t want to let go of his brother because he knew what was coming next. “Give 217 to me. He needs to go down to the basement immediately and get punished.”

“No,” Tomura spoke strongly.

Everything halted.

Izuku’s eyes snapped open, and he held his breath.

“What do you mean no, 117?” Ms. Nagant hissed. “Crying is a *minimum* two-day offense in the basement. He needs to be corrected.”

“It was my fault. I pushed him too hard,” Tomura admitted. “I had given him an intense training session and I think it was too much for him at his level.”

A lie. Tomura lied fluently, Izuku realized.

“117.” Izuku didn’t need to look to know Ms. Nagant was unimpressed. “He needs to get the allocated punishment. He’s thirteen, he knows crying is unacceptable.”

“How about I punish him myself?” Tomura suggested. “He’s mostly my responsibility, correct? I think I need to be the one in charge of his punishments from now on. He’ll receive them better under me.”

Izuku furrowed his brow at what was being proposed.

“Are you sure?” Nine questioned, sounding intrigued. “Do you think you can handle that?”

Tomura nodded. “I’m sure. He responds better to me since I have raised him.”

A drop of silence. Then it gave.

“Fine. I’ll trust you on this one 117,” Nine said. “But *only* because you’re showing more advanced training than the other phase threes. We’ll meet about this tomorrow to discuss further, and I want a full reasoning why you think this is a good idea.”

“Of course. I will be prepared tomorrow. Thank you for your time,” Tomura said, utterly polite. “217. Say thank you to Nine and Ms. Nagant.”

“Thank you,” Izuku whispered into the room. He was confused but endlessly grateful that he didn’t have to go to the basement. “I won’t cry again. I promise.”

“Okay,” Ms. Nagant muttered. “And clean this room up before one of you cuts your foot on glass. I want this place spotless by the morning before your classes. Goodnight 117. Goodnight 217.”

“Good night,” Izuku and Tomura said in unison.

That was enough to suffice their caretakers and they left their room.

When the door clicked shut, Izuku leaned backwards and wiped his eyes. His brother wasn’t smiling, but his face was as soft as he could muster. The scar over his eye and lip was settling in now, and Izuku could feel himself tethered to his last anchor point: his brother.

“See? I won’t let anyone else hurt you anymore,” Tomura explained. He rubbed his back and Izuku calmed down all the way. “No more basement. You can trust me.”

Izuku nodded, fully seeing the truth now: Tomura knew best.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When Izuku got handed his first red folder the following week, he forced himself to feel nothing.

There was no Kacchan.

He had no family.

There was no happy ending awaiting him.

The only person who cared about him was Tomura—his cruel, yet somehow equally broken brother. Fairytales were proving to be just that, tales that were meant to give comfort. But they were not realistic for him because love was not his fate.

Izuku didn't bother memorizing the face or name of the mark. He knew if he did he would empathize with whoever it was, so he avoided it. He allowed himself to be taken somewhere far away in his mind. His new source of comfort was a pitch black like separate dimension. A vast state of nothingness. He felt nothing. Wanted nothing. Even more so, he didn't care to.

He was given a location and a sniper gun from Ms. Nagant. She instructed him to station himself on the rooftop. He was accompanied by Tomura for supervision, but Izuku knew he didn't need it.

When the night fell, Izuku held up the large gun. He pointed it to the window in the dead of night with precision.

Izuku noted quietly that the mark he was given had black hair and square glasses. He was sitting in a room playing some sort of card game with a cigar hanging out of his mouth. Surrounding him were exactly three people who were laughing and lying stacks of cash on the table.

The mark smiled, and Izuku pulled the trigger.

No emotion surged through him. Izuku was simply a ghost residing in his own body. He wasn't the one pulling the trigger, he just observed the Viper side of himself doing so.

He watched the bullet fly true like a song reaching its peak. It was swift, entering through one temple and exiting out the other. The man dropped dead in the room of people, and his body laid there limp on the table. Silent screaming from the others in the room happened. Everyone began scrambling.

Many of them took the money. Izuku watched, appalled by the display of greed.

People really were just like he was taught.

Izuku lowered the gun and looked up at Tomura who was smirking at him.

"Congratulations, little brother," Tomura remarked. "You're officially a viper now."

Along the way home, Tomura stopped and bought him ice cream as a celebration. It made Izuku smile slightly. As he ate his chocolate chip ice cream cone, his emotions began flooding back into him, like a switch that was turned on again. He could feel the heaviness fully envelope him when the weight of what he had done set in.

But Izuku was sad more than anything.

When they got into their room, Tomura was staring at him curiously.

“You should be mindful of your expressions,” Tomura warned softly. “It’s written all over your face that you’re bothered by something. If anyone saw that after an assignment, they would deem you unfit and send you away.”

Izuku nodded. Tomura was right. One of their first lessons was to kill their emotions. Yet here he was, sad while eating ice cream.

Izuku sat down at his desk and stared blankly at himself in the mirror. The ski mask ruffled his thick hair and when he tried to run his hand through it, his fingers hit several snags. Izuku’s shoulders sagged, and he hung his head.

Then a hand was placed on his shoulder, drawing his attention.

Tomura quietly began brushing his hair for him. Izuku teared up slightly at the tenderness and he wanted to say thank you. But his emotions were wrangling his words making it too difficult to speak. Silently, they stayed there as Tomura brushed his hair all the way and kept him calm.

A tear fell down Izuku’s face.

“I can’t control my emotions fully,” Izuku admitted as he wiped away the proof of his weakness. “What should I do? This is dangerous.”

“I know,” Tomura answered. “I’ve got a solution for that, don't worry. I won’t let anyone else hurt you.”

He brushed Izuku’s hair softly and parted it out of his face for him. Izuku stared at the visual of them together through the vanity mirror. He didn’t recognize himself as he searched his face. All he could see staring back at him was the woman who didn’t want him and the freckles that doomed him.

Tomura was looming over him like a protective dark cloud. The gash healed up to be a loud scar on his brother’s face. Izuku felt guilty seeing the deep wound. He had been responsible for that, and Tomura was the only person who ever cared for him through the years.

Tomura put the brush down once Izuku’s hair was detangled.

He then bent down by the desk and pulled out something from a bag. In his hands was a small, silver mask.

Izuku almost flinched slightly at the sight of it. The mask seemed like it was created for a wild animal more than a human. But Izuku didn't move a muscle when Tomura unclasped it and delicately hooked it on his face for him.

If Izuku's body was a coffin, this was the final nail sealing his fate. He could feel it as he gazed at himself in the mirror. All he could see was his destiny that had been decided for him long before he knew it.

"Keep your eyes emotionless," Tomura instructed. "Look down if you have trouble even doing that and your bangs will hide your emotions, and this mask will hide any facial expressions well enough that you'll be able to get by."

Izuku nodded slowly. Tomura was always looking out for him.

"Thank you, big brother."

"Of course." Tomura hummed as he toyed a bit with Izuku's curls to detangle one last knot. "You know, you have to pick a code name eventually. I think Viridian Viper would suit you well."

Viridian.

"Do you like it?" Izuku asked. Because at the end of the day, it never mattered what he wanted.

"I do. I think Viridian would be nice for you."

"Okay. I like Viridian too."

Tomura almost smiled.

Izuku embraced the new identity after that day. The reflection of himself in the mirror with the mask on was an entirely different version of his body.

They went to bed afterwards and in the depths of the night, Izuku kept his secret routine.

He pulled out his romance novel from the floorboard and cracked it open. He didn't read a word however this time, too bitter to read about the life he would never have. He silently stared at the words, mourning all the dreams that drifted far off in his head. One by one they waltzed away and left him behind like everyone else in the world had.

Izuku flipped to the back of the cover page.

He carved two tally marks into the paper with a black pen. One for Sen. One for his first mark.

He shut the book.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you so much!! Please let me know what you think below :') Next chapter is gonna be /that/ chapter revealing the "Incident" as Izuku fully dives into his ranks at the Viper Academy. Super exciting!!

Thank you so so much for reading :D See you next time!

Chapter 19: Entr'acte III

Chapter Summary

Izuku discovers his weakness.

Chapter Notes

Hellooo! Thank you all so much for your patience on this if you're still around! I am officially resettled into life (moved, new job etc) so I can write in peace again ^^ I have been thinking about the latter half of this story for the last year itching to finish it!!! I got the writing bug so I hope you can buckle in :))

First thing first, thank you to the loml, Luna for betaing like always 💕💜💜💜 Now I hope you have a happy time reading!

Warnings: Heavy emphasis on the Graphic Depicts of Violence tag and angst

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 19 — **Entr'acte III**

.

.

.

5 Years until The Incident

A shadow passed on Izuku's left. It was dark, blurry and moving quickly through the dimly lit tunnels. Underneath the pale light, the glimmer of some fancy watch caught Izuku's eye. He spun on his heels precisely, chasing the shadow deeper into the underground labyrinth.

Once Izuku was close enough, the shadow in front of him melted away to reveal a man. The man was stocky and built as if he could crush three men's skulls with his bare hands—and it was *exactly* who Izuku was searching for. It was one of his marks.

His target wove in and out of various hallways, clearly hoping to confuse Izuku. He juked one direction only to slip away in the opposite. This tactic may have worked on any ordinary person. But Izuku was not ordinary.

He was a viper.

“Viridian, there’s one target heading your direction from behind you,” Aoyama’s voice warned through their earpieces. “Be careful not to get ambushed. Blood. Obsidian—go for reinforcement.”

Izuku sucked in a deep breath through his metal mask.

Izuku’s sharp, green eyes honed in on his prey and he picked up the pace. The man in front of him tipped his head back slightly. Their eyes met for a brief moment, and there was unearned amusement in his target’s eyes. His mark smiled as if Izuku had fallen right into his trap but Izuku knew the mark had fallen into a Viper’s pit.

Within the next moment, Izuku could hear several footsteps in various directions. Three, to be exact. He knew two of those footsteps: one maniacally paced one and the other sounded like air, almost too light to hear.

Izuku came to a skidding halt when he breached the mouth of a large, empty room.

Izuku remained calm as he dodged a deadly knife attack. The target went straight for his throat. Typical, predictable and amateurish. Izuku spun quickly to see three other men in all black. A brief moment of assessment allowed Izuku to recognize these men as their prey and he dehumanized them to ants in the next second.

Each man attempted to take several more lethal swipes at him. But Izuku fluidly dodged all attempted kill shots without breaking a sweat. He surgically disarmed one man then successfully flung a blade from his waistband between the man’s eyes.

The pest fell to the floor with a heavy thud, dead.

“I told you not to get ambushed,” Aoyama sighed in the ear piece.

“I’m not,” Izuku said flatly as he disarmed the next target and then brutally head butted him to disorient the man. “You said *one*. There are three new targets here.”

“Good thing you’re never alone then.”

Izuku looked up when he heard the signature metal rattle of Himiko.

She dropped down from up above, revealing herself from the darkness. Her landing shook the ground, stunning the remaining three targets in the room. Her crazed eyes peered from underneath her curtain bangs like a wild animal and her malicious grin was on full display.

She was dressed in the same all black attire as Izuku but in her hands was a long metal chain that had blades welded to both ends.

Himiko gripped her weapon with homicidal delight.

Before the targets could react, she slung her weapon with pure violent volition. The blade pierced the heart of one man and his eyes bulged so far Izuku thought they might pop. The

grin on her face split wider at the sight of the dripping blood.

She then moved like a spider as she slithered around the target. She wrapped the cold chain around his throat and tightened it until the man was choking and gasping.

“The sound of a dying man is my favorite melody,” Himiko hummed sweetly. “But the sight of blood is even more satisfying to me.”

She pulled and pulled the chain until the man’s face turned purple. Then with one final, violent tug, she broke his neck with no remorse.

The body slumped to the ground and the last two targets were frozen in fear.

After Himiko licked the man’s blood, Izuku took a relaxed stance. He watched as the rest of his unit revealed themselves, writhing out from various shadowy corners.

Across the large room, Jin quietly crawled out from underneath a vent. His bright, white smile gleamed as he cut one target’s Achilles’ heel in a single swipe. The target cried out and now all eyes were on Jin.

Jin’s eerie laughter filled the air as he smiled in a way that was purely him: unhinged and bellicose. The target he injured tried to shoot him but Jin swiftly dodged. Jin drew his own pistol and fired a sharp bullet into the man’s skull. The body slumped down to the ground.

Next to reveal themselves was Ibara. Her long graceful, emerald colored hair always felt out of place to Izuku. She was too ethereal to be here with them. But when she pulled out her thorned whip, Izuku was reminded why she was chosen for this unit.

“I pray your soul finds guidance in the next life,” she whispered too softly as she launched her whip to wrap tightly around the man’s throat.

The tiny, metal thorns on the whip sunk into the target’s flesh and bled him out immediately. A croak was heard and blood sprayed across Ibara’s jumpsuit. An instant kill. There was no enjoyment in the murder like there always was with Himiko or Jin. Her face stayed emotionless and stale much like Izuku’s.

Their eyes met for a brief moment then Izuku averted his gaze when he felt the hairs on the back of his neck stand up. Izuku whirled around to see three more targets enter the scene, blazing. They went straight for Izuku with reckless abandon.

Izuku moved out of the way and went on the attack immediately.

But before he could go hand to hand with the new targets, another Viper came into the room.

Hiryu slid into the midst of battle with all the grace of death.

His dark, obsidian colored eyes were deeply focused as he kept his eyes trained on their prey. Without exchanging a word, Izuku and Hiryu fell into a familiar pattern of partnered fighting. They blended with their knives and dodged against the three men without gaining a single scratch. The two fought back to back, and overpowered the two others.

It wasn't before long that Hiryu cut one man's throat and Izuku snapped the other's neck.

All Viper eyes locked on to the final target in the room.

"Five against one isn't good odds, Goro," Hiryu warned their mark. "It would be wise to come with us and give any information on where you're operating so we can end this now."

Hiryu stood up straight and lowered his black bandana off his face. His long ponytail swayed with the breeze that was flowing out from the vents.

Izuku glanced at Hiryu and then glanced at the target. Izuku could tell there was a look in Hiryu's eyes that reflected some level of restraint.

Quickly, the target held up a gun with shaky hands.

"You can all eat my shit," Goro spat. He cocked his gun and held it up with shaky arms. "Go to hell! You fucking *snakes* can't tell me what to do!"

Izuku tried to keep himself from growing annoyed. This was taking longer than it should have.

They were assigned to hunt down the man in front of them. His name was Goro and he was a fledging crime lord who had been encroaching on Yakuza territory. Despite his warning to back off from the Yakuza heir himself, Chisaki Kai, Goro kept on doing all the crap he was instructed not to.

Now here they all were in some dingy factory's basement.

Chisaki had given simple instructions: bring in the pest and exterminate *all* his wannabe lackeys.

"I would listen to our dear Obsidian Viper." Himiko laughed. She swung her chain around with a lopsided grin. "He's the *reasonable* one out of the lot of us."

Goro's upper lip curled and he whirled his gun towards Himiko. "I thought you were the Viper *Seven*? Where's the other two?"

"One is in our ear if you must know," Jin offered. He picked dried blood from underneath his nails without glancing up. "Sparkling Viper isn't much of a fighter, but he's good with electronics. Even if you manage to escape, he'll track down your location just like he did today."

That seemed to get underneath Goro's skin. The man bristled, and his eyes anxiously darted around at all of them.

"Vipers, we shouldn't provoke him," Ibara warned, offering some sage advice. "It'll make him skittish."

Ibara was correct, like always, but it was her words that set him off.

Goro started shaking so hard Izuku was worried he might implode—and he did. Goro screamed loudly, setting them all into defensive positions but he moved in a way that was too erratic for any of them to predict.

He randomly fired off his gun—and it struck Izuku right in the shoulder.

Izuku grunted as the bullet sunk into his skin. He went stumbling backwards from the impact and his legs quaked with adrenaline. Izuku absorbed the blow like he was trained and he steadied himself through sheer will.

White specks flickered across his vision and several things happened at once: Hiryu rushed over to him, helped steady him, and applied pressure on the wound. Ibara and Jin immediately restrained Goro, throwing him down with unnecessary force and Himiko started cackling maniacally. She threw her head back and wiped the blood off her lips.

“That was the *wrong* Viper to shoot,” Himiko teased. She tilted her head and tutted her finger. “You hurt the little one and you get the *big* one in return.”

A single footstep is all it took to change the mood of the room.

Izuku stiffened.

Hiryu grew agitated.

Ibara’s blank mask slipped to reveal weariness.

Jin’s lips pressed in a thin line and Himiko, even though she was amused, her chuckles immediately died. Slowly, a new threatening presence entered the scene. Izuku didn’t have to look behind him to know who it was.

The Horned Viper.

The long wound stretching over Tomura’s right eye had healed to leave a nasty scar. But he embraced it just as though he was born with it. He was dressed in all black like the rest of them, but he no longer bothered to wear a mask. On his back were his two sharpened machetes in the shape of an X.

Tomura had shot up in height, standing at a powerful 187cm and his muscles were taut in whatever he wore. His long silver hair was pulled up into a messy bun, revealing his mark ‘117’ at the base of his nape. Over the past two years, Tomura gained an interest in tattooing his body. An endless sea of horned vipers were inked on his neck, all baring their fangs towards his strong jawline.

He flexed his large hands and the ripples of his skin made the river of inked snakes covering his hands and arms dance. Across his battered knuckles were the words “VIPER” and “SNAKE” in big, bold lettering. Accompanying all of this were also sharp, terrifying piercings. Pierced eyebrows. Pierced ears. Pierced bottom lip with silver snake bites.

Tomura now looked as noxious as he was.

Hiryu peeled himself away from Izuku when Tomura sauntered towards them.

Izuku stood up straight as if he wasn't hurt. Tomura and Hiryu exchanged an unreadable passing pair of glances that held simmering rivalry. Then Tomura placed a hand a little *too* gently on Izuku's shoulder and inspected the wound.

Cold, crimson eyes stared down into Izuku.

"I'll deal with you later," Tomura whispered only for Izuku to hear.

Izuku's stomach knotted. He had messed up.

Tomura cut his eye towards their mark and with a simple hand gesture, motioned for Ibara and Jin to lift Goro. The two did as they were instructed and forced Goro onto his feet with his arms twisted behind his back. Goro's bottom lip was split open and his eyes were wild. He looked fearful of the six figures in front of him, eyeing him up and down.

"We were going to take you alive and unharmed originally," Tomura said through an exasperated sigh. He walked forward without haste and placed on a pair of leather gloves neatly. "But, I don't take too kindly to the injuries of my favorite brother." He rolled up his sleeves and placed himself directly in front of Goro. "I hope you understand."

Goro started squirming when Tomura lifted up his hands. Tomura positioned his thumbs directly over Goro's eyes and held tightly onto his skull.

"—What do you think you're doing?" Hiryu hissed. He stepped forward bravely and grabbed Tomura's arm. "We need him *alive*."

Silence.

Everyone's eyes were on Hiryu now.

"Do you think I am an idiot?" Tomura asked carefully. "I am blinding him, not killing him."

"But we need him to tell us where the rest of his organization is located," Hiryu tried to reason. He glared at Tomura. "This is not the time to get your sick kicks."

"Am I taking out his *tongue*?" Tomura quipped. "He will still be able to speak and he will give up the information. This is for injuring one of our own, I do not let that go so simply."

Hiryu and Tomura entered a staring contest for dominance and silence fell over their unit.

This had been happening more and more recently and Izuku couldn't figure out why.

In the middle of the glare off, Izuku shifted on his feet when he felt the burn of Jin and Himiko's eyes. They were scowling at him, probably blaming him for the tension in the air no doubt. They always regarded him as if he was a spoiled brat who wasn't supposed to be there.

Jin and Himiko never let go of their grudge about Sen after all these years. They thought Izuku was a part of their unit because he was riding the coattail of Tomura. They credited Izuku's extreme success in the academy to getting lucky that he was the Little Brother of Tomura, who seemed so fiercely protective of him.

However, Izuku knew why Tomura was *really* hurting this man.

It wasn't out of protectiveness but rather it was punishment for Izuku. Tomura was the only person who knew Izuku was defective with empathy. Every time Izuku messed up, Tomura made sure to inflict pain onto the person who did it as a punishment for Izuku: *look what you made me do.* It was a subtle reminder for Izuku of what Tomura was capable of.

When a minute passed, Hiryu lost the stare off.

Hiryu begrudgingly lowered his head, however disapproval was deeply etched into his face. Tomura scoffed and shrugged Hiryu off of him like he was a flea and returned his deadly gaze back onto Goro.

Goro was crying and begging for an ounce of mercy.

He could beg forever, Izuku thought sourly. Mercy was not something Tomura understood.

Izuku kept his eyes lowered to the ground as Tomura blinded the man with his thumbs. The screams mixed with the quenching sound and blood slowly pooled at Tomura's boots. There were a mush of words that fumbled out, and every location of his operations was listed into the air as a possible bargain for his sight—but Tomura kept all his promises.

When the act was finished, Ibara and Jin let go of Goro who crashed to the ground.

The failed gang leader sobbed and held his newly deformed face with anguish. Tomura stood above him with not a single thread of sympathy woven into his face. Izuku studied Tomura's bloodied hands and watched how they dropped to his side.

Izuku blinked once, and within that second Tomura whirled onto Hiryu—punching him in the nose so violently it jerked everyone into a surprise gasp.

Hiryu staggered and then another blow was laid on him. An upper cut as fast as lightning was the next hit and before Hiryu could fall, Tomura grabbed Hiryu by the jaw, smearing Goro's blood on his face in the process. Hiryu grunted in pain as he was gripped in a bruising hold.

Lethal hatred sunk into Tomura's face and he spoke his next words viciously.

"Know your place, Obsidian," Tomura threatened. "Nine made *me* the leader of this unit, not *you*. I don't give a shit if you are second in command. If you question me in front of our team again I'll cut your goddamn tongue out and make you swallow it."

Tomura shoved Hiryu backwards with so much force that Hiryu fell to the ground and hit his head.

“Everyone, *move out*,” Tomura commanded with an icy edge. “Obsidian. Viridian. Transport the target to Chisaki’s drop off.”

Tomura left the room and immediately Jin and Ibara followed suit. Himiko glanced at Izuku with a look of subtle disgust, shook her head, and followed the rest of the team.

Izuku waited until the footsteps were out of earshot before exhaling. He unclasped his metal mask and hooked it to his side. He looked down on the ground at the two men in very different positions. Goro was crawling around in agony mourning his sight and Hiryu was sitting cross legged on the floor nursing his sure to be broken nose.

Izuku walked over to Goro and unbuckled a blue syringe from his belt. He uncapped it, flicked the needle and used his foot to pin the disfigured man on the ground.

“Pl-Please, I’m sorry,” Goro tried to reason. “Tell Chisaki I will call off all operations—”

Izuku tuned him out as he pushed the needle into Goro’s neck.

A scream. A cry. Two things Izuku has become numb to. He injected the blue liquid into Goro’s veins without blinking and within two short breaths the man was out cold.

“Goro will be under for the next six hours,” Izuku muttered tiredly. “That gives us time to drop him off across town.”

Hiryu grunted in return.

Izuku turned to his older brother with a level of sympathy. He pulled out disinfectant from his small pack and handed it to Hiryu, who gladly took it.

Izuku removed his ear piece then turned it off just in case Aoyama was still listening in. Hiryu did the same, but was a lot more frustration. Izuku didn’t flinch as Hiryu flung the ear piece across the room with all his strength and it broke against the wall.

“Fuck Tomura,” Hiryu said in Korean. “*Fuck* him. I can’t stand him.”

“Why? Because Nine made him first in command over you?” Izuku switched to Korean as well because he valued his life.

Korean was the *one* language Tomura never bothered to learn.

Tomura insisted on learning Latin to try to make himself stand out and it worked like a charm. Nine thought it was a good idea since a lot of secret code in their world of assassins used dead languages.

When Nine approved Tomura to switch to learning Latin in place for Korean, like true followers, many other vipers followed suit. Everyone wanted to be as high achieving as Tomura so many got to choose between either Latin or Korean.

Now, because of that small drift, Izuku and Hiryu were the only two in The Viper Seven unit who were fluent in Korean. To Izuku, it was their personal language and whenever they were

alone they naturally bled into it to feel secure.

“My issues with him aren’t about who is the goddamn leader. It’s—” Hiryu licked his lips and took in a shaky breath. “Never mind. You wouldn’t understand. Not anymore anyways.”

“No matter what is going on you shouldn’t test him like that, hyung,” Izuku warned and ignored the jab. “He’s starting to lose more and more patience recently.”

“Trust me, he’s not the only one,” Hiryu grumbled.

Izuku made a face at that statement—it was off.

However, Izuku was worn down after this assignment and wished to get it over with. He knew he had a lecture coming from Tomura for getting himself shot and his shoulder was throbbing. Sparing no more energy, Izuku turned his back on Hiryu to tie up Goro and address his own wound.

If Izuku had watched Hiryu closer he would have seen something on Hiryu’s face that had never been there before: sadness.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku embraced the feeling of nothingness that coursed through his veins.

Every day was routine at this point: find the targets, exterminate them, and make sure no loose ends were left behind. Izuku could do it with his eyes closed now, and sometimes he did.

After they delivered Goro to the Yakuza drop site, their unit returned back to The Academy together.

They walked into their building covered in blood and all at once everyone’s eyes turned to them. Some people regarded them with admiration. Others held back jealousy because they weren’t chosen to be a part of the unit: The Viper Seven.

Nine’s best of the best.

Jin: The Double Headed Viper. He was granted the codename for how quick his personality could flip. He went from happy to happy to murder in mere seconds, and he held no hesitation in making sure the assignment was done. His number was 110 and he had it tattooed on the palm of his hand. And as a *small* piece of sentiment, he got his other palm tattooed with 110 as an ode to Sen—to carry on his memory. On his biceps were tattooed vipers that leaked down to his elbows.

Next was Ibara: the Thorned Viper. Her number 199 was directly on her right shoulder blade, and she had a tattoo of a snake and thorny wire intertwining around the mark in a circle. She gained the name Thorned Viper for her use of weapons that always had spikes. At some point, she began praying before killing after she learned what religion was.

It was odd to Izuku how strongly she clung to the concept. When he had asked her why once, she simply said it was because it helped her embrace her destined role as executioner in this life. Everyone left it at that since it dealt with killing. Her resolve for being a murderer was so strong it caught Nine's attention.

Himiko became known as the Blood Viper. Less of a codename and more of a general statement due to her craze for blood. She proudly displayed her number 200 on her ankle and tattooed two twin vipers on the back of her legs. Her bloodlust made her unstoppable, and that type of excitement for homicide is exactly what landed her on their unit.

Aoyama was the biggest surprise of the people chosen by Nine. He was given the codename The Sparkling Viper because of his charm and how well he worked with shiny, pristine electronics. He never was much of a fighter on the field but his hacking and tracking skill set was unmatched. It must've been fateful foreshadowing that his number 215 was on his wrist since that was the part of his body he used the most.

Hiryu was an addition everyone expected as if he was a crowned prince in line for a throne. The Obsidian Viper aka 102. He was given the name for his jet black hair and inky eyes. In all their years at the academy, Hiryu was always neck and neck with Tomura for top of the pack. The only thing that differed between him and Tomura was their drive.

Tomura was driven by pleasure from cruelty and approval from Nine.

Hiryu—*well*.

Hiryu never let anyone know what he was driven by. Hiryu always touched his number 102 on his trigger finger often, staring at it with an unreadable expression.

And then there was Tomura: The Horned Viper aka 117. His code name was given to him directly by Nine for how well he represented the Academy's values. The Horned Viper was one of the most dangerous vipers, so everyone assumed that's why he was given that name. However, Izuku speculated Tomura was given Horned because it was closely related to the imagery of a demon.

Then lastly there was Izuku: The Viridian Viper. A perfect kill streak and unbeatable in sparring matches because of his speed.

The '*untouchable*' Viper is what many of his siblings snidely referred to him as. He was untouchable to everyone *but* Tomura—a deal hashed out with Nine exactly two years ago. While everyone else was tortured in the basement for punishment, Izuku was dragged away by Tomura to their room for some mystery scolding no one else saw.

The favoritism bred tangible resentment because most other vipers assumed Tomura didn't do anything to him.

But the vipers in The Viper Seven knew better.

Everyone who was a part of their unit saw the bruises on Izuku's skin clear as day any time after he messed up on a mission. Himiko and Jin would smile at the pain inflicted. Ibara and

Aoyama were indifferent.

Hiryu, however, had his opinions written across his whole face. His mouth would twist like he tasted something sour whenever he spotted the black eyes and busted lips on Izuku.

But Hiryu never said anything and Izuku never made it seem like Tomura's punishments hurt.

It was part of their dynamic to never discuss it.

Izuku was fifteen now, and he had proved his worth to Nine by following Tomura's instructions. In the process he was protected against any possible death sentencing.

Izuku was thankful for this because his emotional defect caused him to have significant issues when he was thirteen. Tomura never told anyone about how rough that year was. Izuku's outbursts, his crying spells, and the countless night terrors were hard to deal with for both of them.

But Tomura reported that Izuku was the perfect Viper until the day he finally was.

Now, Izuku's emotions were as dull as a forgotten blade.

He never tended to them any more. All the feelings of joy, sadness, anger, were long lost memories over the last two years. His highs and lows were locked away in a forgotten part of his mind and he preferred it like that. Izuku's kill streak was as perfect as Tomura's and he obeyed every command Tomura gave him.

He owed Tomura his life because without his brother, he surely would be dead by now.

Tomura was truly his one protector, and his brother made sure to remind him of that daily.

Like now, they were walking back up to their *shared* suite.

Everyone chosen for The Viper Seven had gotten living quarter upgrades on the highest floor of their skyscraper cluster of a home. A perk and obvious tactic of favoritism on Nine's behalf. He flaunted how lavish he treated their unit to everyone in The Academy to help inspire cruelty for personal gain—and it worked.

From what Izuku heard in the Tokyo underground grapevine, their Academy produced some of the most ruthless assassins.

Their old rooms were forgotten and now they lived in lush suites. Ibara, Jin, Himiko, Aoyama and Hiryu all had nice suites overlooking the twinkling city. Each were one bedroom apartments with living rooms, kitchens and anything they wanted. Ibara got a piano, and Himiko had a special room for her knife collection. Aoyama was given the finest technology in his room, and an office suite where he could work from if he wanted to.

Izuku originally was *so* excited for this new arrangement. The temptation of privacy and space was sort of appealing. But his half forged dreams were cut down immediately.

Nine informed him that Tomura *requested* they stay together—and what Tomura wanted would always override anything Izuku desired.

They had one large bedroom, big enough for two queen sized beds. Two bathrooms. One living room and one kitchen. They had a third room specifically for private training sessions, and Tomura was even given his own office room inside the suite to do the special paperwork Nine entrusted him with.

When Izuku asked Tomura why he requested they stay together, the answer was simple: "You're not ready to live on your own yet, you still need me."

Izuku didn't question him. It was probably true.

Which brought them to this moment, in their suite. When the door closed behind them, Izuku could feel the energy shift.

Tomura examined Izuku's gunshot wound with displeasure and clicked his tongue.

"You're unreasonably clumsy," Tomura chastised. With one hand he grabbed Izuku's shoulders gently and with the other he fixed his head of curls. "If Nine heard about this you would be forced to take on an extra month of evasive technique training—do you know how lucky you are to have me?"

Izuku hung his head. "Yes. Thank you for always looking after me."

"How did you let that untrained swine shoot you anyways?"

"He was swinging the gun around in a manner that was unpredictable. I'm sorry."

"Not a valid excuse," Tomura reprimanded coldly. Izuku winced visibly as Tomura took his thumb and dug it into the bullet wound. "Do better next time. Are we understood?"

"Ye-Yes," Izuku stammered as he felt his wound reopen and spill fresh blood. "I understand."

"You understand—*what*?"

"I understand, *Big Brother*," Izuku gritted out.

Izuku clenched his fists as numbing pain shot from his shoulder down to his finger tips. Tomura stared at him for a while, searching his face for any hints of agony but Izuku didn't let it slip.

This was a test: *how well could he mask pain?* Tomura never stopped testing him.

After a minute, Tomura removed his thumb from the wound and Izuku internally shuttered. Tomura's piercing eyes fastened onto him with unreadable emotion. Izuku stared back, mirroring the same blankness until Tomura finally spun on his heel.

"You're dismissed," Tomura muttered. "Go tend to your wound and if this happens again we're going to have one on one bullet dodging training."

Izuku nodded, and left their suite.

ᔓᔓᔓ

After patching himself up, Izuku needed to decompress. Whenever he needed some place to be himself unguarded, he really only had one person to turn to.

Izuku knocked on Hiryu's door.

At first there was no answer, but that's what he expected. He knocked again, and on cue, Hiryu's long grunt echoed on the other side. The door swung open up revealing an exhausted Hiryu with a bandaged bloody nose.

Izuku smiled shyly and held up the bucket in his hands.

"I brought you some ice for your nose, hyung," Izuku switched to Korean naturally with a slightly forced smile.

Unable to resist, Hiryu softly smiled back. He opened the door wide for Izuku to come in and they exchanged silent understanding glances at each others wounds. Izuku shut the door behind him and shuffled inside, stepping over the heap of dirty clothes that was always in the middle of the room.

Izuku offered an empathic smile as he took the towel he brought and carefully loaded it with cold ice.

Hiryu sat on the bed and winced as Izuku iced his wounds for him.

"Thanks," Hiryu muttered in Korean. He closed his eyes, allowing Izuku to take care of him.

Izuku hummed as he applied pressure on the broken nose bridge and inspected it. His eyes flickered across Hiryu's tightly tensed brow.

"You seem more irritable than usual," Izuku pointed out. They switched their conversation to Korean all the way.

"Because I *am*." Hiryu huffed and took the towel of ice from Izuku. "I'm sick of dealing with Tomura's superiority complex."

"If you just keep your head down, it'll be okay. Tomura is only ever violent with his own team if provoked."

"*If provoked*?" Hiryu scoffed and rolled his eyes. "That bastard really has you feeding out of his palm nowadays, doesn't he?"

"Tomura only wants what's best for us."

"Tomura wants what's best for *Tomura*," Hiryu corrected with hate laced in his voice. "You're too blinded by him to even see it. Have you ever wondered why he wants to be the one to punish you solely? Don't you find that *odd*?"

“I know why my punishments are private,” Izuku defended. “That’s between Tomura and I.”

“Exactly,” Hiryu sneered. “Between *you two,* which is weird. Look around at this place, Izuku. Nothing in this hell hole doesn’t go through Nine first. Nine knows when everyone fucking breathes, eats and shits yet *somehow* Tomura weaseled you out of Nine’s viewpoint.”

“Hiryu, you’re talking strange. You might need to lay down from the loss of blood—”

“Tell me: if Tomura told you a command opposite of Nine’s, who would you obey?”

Izuku instantly opened his mouth. He was ready to blurt out the obvious answer but froze.

A vision of Tomura’s threatening glare leaked into his consciousness and Izuku slowly closed his mouth.

“Think about why you hesitated on that answer, Izuku,” Hiryu said, voice heavy with caution. Hiryu was disappointed but not surprised. “I don’t say this to be spiteful, but be *careful* with Tomura. He’s playing a long game that I only recently think I noticed. Pay attention to the way he gazes at Nine when he thinks no one is watching, it’s *frightening*. I used to think he looked at Nine with admiration—but it’s really envy.”

Izuku shook his head. “That’s nonsense.”

“I’m not expecting you to believe me right now. Observe him around Nine next time and you’ll see what I mean.”

Izuku kept shaking his head until he rattled those words right out of his ears. Hiryu didn’t like Tomura, he never has and never will. It was an absurd thought that Tomura envied Nine, and besides, what would Tomura even envy Nine for?

Power, a voice deep in the back of Izuku’s mind answered. *Control*.

Izuku stilled at the taboo thought.

“What’s gotten into you lately?” Izuku muttered. He flopped down next to Hiryu on his bed with a light bounce. “All these hypotheticals you’ve been dwelling on aren’t like you. Usually we talk about ice cream flavors or some type of food you want to try on the next assignment. Let’s go back to talking about ramen.”

“I don’t want to talk about ramen.”

“Then what do you want to talk about that’s *not* Tomura?”

Hiryu locked eyes with Izuku and shifted on the bed.

“Can I tell you a secret, Izuku?”

“Of course, hyung.”

Hiryu grabbed Izuku’s hand tightly, startling Izuku.

“I mean it,” Hiryu whispered desperately. “I-I want to talk to you as *Izuku*. Not as The Viridian Viper. Not as Tomura’s Little Brother. Not even as a *viper*. I want to talk to the *Izuku* that used to exist two years ago who had a spark of life in his eyes.”

At those words, Izuku’s heart skipped a beat. Hearing himself described in a potential way that was not directly related to him being a Viper or Tomura’s little brother was odd. Just Izuku? Just be *Izuku*? The emotion of individualism rose inside of him for the first time in a while, sparking a small flicker of luminosity in his usually dead eyes.

“There he is,” Hiryu smiled proudly at the tiny light in Izuku’s eyes. “Some bit of you is alive in there.”

Izuku scrunched his face, utterly confused. “Hiryu, what’s going on with you—”

“—I’m in love with someone from the outside.”

Izuku’s stomach dropped straight to the floor.

“Wh-what?!” Izuku nearly screamed, sitting up on the bed.

“Shh, keep it down!” Hiryu hissed. He clasped a hand over Izuku’s mouth. When Izuku calmed down, Hiryu released him but Izuku was still panicking.

“S-Sorry,” Izuku whispered quietly. “I’m—I’m *surprised*—how—or who—o-or *when*?”

“Her name is Kanna,” Hiryu said so hush it was barely audible. “I met her on a solo assignment about a year ago in Tokyo. I had extra time and decided to walk around and found myself talking to her at a zoo. Next thing I know I am volunteering for all the missions here in Tokyo I can get my hands on just to see her. I even spend a lot of my free time after missions out with her on dates.”

Izuku was stunned to near silence. “Hiryu…th-this is dangerous.”

“I know.” Hiryu’s voice wobbled. He clenched his jaw. He laid back on the bed with Izuku and they both stared at each other knowing this was playing with fire. “B-But she’s worth it, Izuku. I’ve never felt anything like this before. I feel…I feel like we’re fated.”

A tiny bit of warmth bled into Izuku’s veins for the first time in two years. Fate wasn’t a word Izuku had heard since the old violinist said it to him. Hearing fate was enough to make Izuku’s emotions slowly thaw back to life.

But he didn’t know which emotion to let take control: the fear, the confusion, or the tiniest bit of joy underneath all the layers.

As he looked into Hiryu’s eyes, full of love, Izuku decided to choose joy.

“Tell me about her then.”

Hiryu talked about Kanna like she was made of fairytales. He spoke about her hair like it was crafted of silver and as if her eyes were gems carved especially made for gazing upon him.

He had never heard Hiryu speak about anyone this way before, and Izuku feared this infatuation would be Hiryu's damnation.

Izuku allowed his mind to wander back to the one person he forbade himself from ever thinking about.

Kacchan.

Izuku's eyes swelled with tears that didn't quite fall as he began imagining the missing boy from his childhood.

There had been times Izuku wished he could remember Kacchan's real name. He tried now, wondering what it really was—but the memory was too far out of reach now like a phantom in the wind. However, Izuku could still hear Kacchan's laugh and see his smile. Izuku could perfectly envision the dust blond hair and shiny red eyes that he was always fixated on.

He wondered what it would be like now, how handsome Kacchan probably was with those features.

As Hiryu talked about love, out of nowhere a floodgate of ignored emotions rocked Izuku. His thoughts on Kacchan came dangerously close to the surface.

Yearning barreled into his chest. Hurt clutched his eyes, and desperation for a soft touch stopped his breathing. Izuku blinked rapidly, and shut down the onset of mixed emotions that took him off guard. He buried it back down, underneath all the parts of him that he had to ignore.

"Izuku?" Hiryu asked wearily when Izuku's hand started to shake lightly. "Are you okay?"

"I-I'm fine," Izuku lied. He clutched his trembling fingers with his other hand and forced them to still. When the shaking subdued, Izuku pinned a forced smile on his lips. "Just happy for you, hyung,"

Izuku willed away the imagery of the missing blond boy and was relieved to feel his emotions finally subdue.

He made a mental note to be careful thinking about Kacchan, and he was unsure what exactly those emotions were.

Hiryu blinked rapidly, but was happily relieved to see Izuku emote in front of him for the first time in two years.

"Please, tell me more," Izuku said quickly. He needed to get his mind off the concept of Kacchan. "I want to hear everything you like about her."

The smile Hiryu gave was so bright.

Over the next several weeks, Hiryu and Izuku grew closer. A tiny, invisible barrier had been lifted between them as they bonded over their mutual, forbidden belief in romance.

The whole fiasco left Izuku internally quaking. It was as if he was reaching into a taboo cookie jar that poisoned him once before. He knew he shouldn't, but he was *so* tempted to give into his fascination about love and people on the outside now that Hiryu showed him that it was *possible*.

One night, Izuku felt brave enough to tell Hiryu about Kacchan in detail.

Hiryu was nearly speechless but thankful Izuku confided in him. For the first time in two years, Izuku experienced a hug, but this one was different from the one Tomura had given him when he was thirteen. Hiryu hugged him like he wanted to, Tomura had done it like he had to. This hug was warm, and protective. Tomura's was cold and possessive.

Izuku was stunned at the softness. His body was confused mostly. He had become so accustom to only being touched violently that he had forgotten what it was like to be held tenderly. He shakily wrapped his arms around Hiryu, treasuring the warmth as Hiryu stroked his hair.

"I'm so sorry, Izuku," Hiryu murmured.

Izuku didn't reply, just clung to his older brother harder.

After that night, Hiryu started to take pity on him. There was a dejected look in Hiryu's eye whenever he stared down at Izuku's tattoo on his collar bone. Izuku then noted this was the same stare Hiryu would always gaze at his own '102' tattoo with.

Hiryu began to offer Izuku to come with him on duo missions in Tokyo so he could help cover for him on dates.

Izuku nodded eagerly, and he cherished every moment.

When they would finish an assignment, Hiryu would quickly change into citizen clothing. Izuku would text Tomura saying that he and Hiryu were out late, grabbing food or watching a movie.

Tomura believed him, there was no reason not to.

Hiryu would then run off with his girlfriend and Izuku would watch over the date from the viewpoint of the closet rooftop with his binoculars.

During these starless nights, Izuku saw the unbelievable with his own two eyes: someone like him being loved and in love. It was like a bizarre daydream, seeing his lethal sibling walking hand in hand with a normal woman who blushed simply by looking at Hiryu.

But he questioned if it was truly *real* love often.

Tomura always painfully pointed out that if normal outsiders ever found out they were trained killers from birth, there would be witch hunts. The average person would cower away

from them, and back away with fear in their eyes. The police will be signaled, chaos will ensue, and the Governor would leave them high and dry to cover the fact their program was funded by tax dollars. It was the whole reason fornication outside of their approved circles was banned.

But Izuku still wondered if Kanna would love Hiryu the same if she knew that he was a trained killer.

The realistic part of him was extremely doubtful.

The hopeless romantic side of him liked to think love would conquer all.

While observing Hiryu and his girlfriend one day in the park, Izuku's mind unwillingly wandered back to Kacchan. His heart twisted with the same, volatile mixed emotions.

A bubble of bitterness surfaced to tell him he was abandoned by Kacchan. But then a gust of hope told him Kacchan would come back for him. Even if he couldn't go with Kacchan—at least he would have the comfort that his childhood play-husband came back for him.

However, Izuku buried both of those thoughts for his own sanity.

Izuku forcefully concluded that his childhood friend was dead.

Even if Kacchan wasn't—the other boy was a past chapter in Izuku's life. To avoid his feelings consuming him, Izuku funneled all his broken dreams into Hiryu in the hopes they would come out whole on the other side.

Every night after assignment debriefs, Izuku and Hiryu snuck away to a private rooftop and talked about potential romantic things Hiryu could do with his girlfriend.

"Have you ever bought her flowers?" Izuku asked in Korean with a large grin. He leaned back on the concrete roof with his elbows and stared up at the cloudy sky above Tokyo.

"She's allergic," Hiryu answered with a laugh. He lit his cigarette with grace and Izuku welcomed the slight scent of nicotine that wafted into his nose. "I would feel like an asshole getting something that would just make her sneeze all day."

"What about a potted plant then? That would be a thoughtful gesture."

Hiryu snapped his fingers with a lopsided grin at Izuku. "Ah, that's a great idea! But what type of plant? I don't know much about what kind of houseplants are good gifts."

Izuku hummed and tilted his head. "I can help you pick out one when we get the chance!"

"Perfect. Thanks, Izuku." Hiryu softly smiled at Izuku before saying, "maybe one day I can introduce you to her. Y'know, have her meet my family. It would mean a lot."

A hopeful pang echoed in Izuku's chest, but soon the clutches of dread overshadowed it.

He could perfectly envision Tomura's angry, disapproving stare and hear his voice in his ears: *"would you really throw away everything I've done to keep you alive? Is that how you would repay me?"*

Izuku averted his eyes from Hiryu and hesitantly opened his mouth.

"I-I don't know about that Hiryu—"

Izuku's answer was cut off by the sound of their twin digital watches beeping. In sync, both Izuku and Hiryu read the message that flashed across their tiny digital screens. It was a notification from Tomura that The Viper Seven had a full week assignment starting tomorrow night.

The lightheartedness of the moment escaped and Izuku eyed Hiryu.

Hiryu took a long drag from his cigarette. He studied the number '102' on his trigger finger then side eye'd Izuku's '217'.

Izuku watched as the gray smoke floated upwards and blended with the night sky.

"What are you going to do in the long run, hyung?" Izuku whispered. "Have you even told Kanna what you are or what you do?"

"…No." Hiryu admitted. Pain danced across his face. "She thinks I work crazy hours in pharmaceuticals and I don't plan on telling her the truth about what we are."

Izuku pursed his lips. He felt like he knew that answer but pressed on. "Why not tell her?"

"Because I don't want her to look at me like I'm a *monster*," Hiryu grumbled under his breath. He took another long drag of his cigarette. "I don't think my heart could take it. She's too much of a humanitarian to ever understand what we've been through and telling her would only put her in danger."

"But if she loves you, she'll accept you for who you are. Right?"

"All love has limitations," Hiryu said sadly. "Besides, my biggest worry is The Academy finding out I'm this deeply *defective*. They would have my goddamn head if they found out I was in this deep with an outsider."

"They would," Izuku muttered. He took a moment to think about their home and their twisted family. "Have you noticed that there's been a halt in kids coming in?"

"Everyone has noticed." Hiryu shrugged. "There hasn't been a new class in years."

It was an unspoken elephant in their lives.

The rooms for the younger kids were barren like a desert these days. There was always an edge in Ms. Nagant's voice whenever she was asked about this. Izuku's class was the last one, and everyone was anticipating getting a Little soon—yet they never came.

“I’ve been eavesdropping on Ms. Nagant when she thinks everyone is gone,” Izuku admitted. “The supplier, Peter Moore, and The Academy are having some internal friction on the grounds of wastefulness…I don’t think there’s going to be a next cohort.”

Hiryu remained silent as he thumbed his tattoo of 102 thoughtfully.

“Good.”



The next day, they departed for their week-long mission, and in a short summary: it was a shit show.

There had been a tangible shift in both Hiryu and Tomura over the last several weeks. Tomura was growing more cold, and far less lenient on mistakes. In contrast, Hiryu was becoming compassionate and clearly pulling his punches. Kanna was melting his heart and replacing all the viciousness Hiryu had been trained for with kindness.

But unlike Izuku, Hiryu didn’t have any training on how to mask his defect.

The two leads of The Viper Seven clashed like titans together during this particular assignment. By day seven, they came to fist to fist blows over a small mistake Izuku had made. Izuku had accidentally been seen by an unmarked target that was hiding in the shadows. Izuku quickly neutralized the threat before any alarms were sounded.

But this wasn’t good enough for Tomura.

Tomura needed *perfection*.

By the end of the mission, it came as no surprise to Izuku that Tomura back handed him hard enough for Izuku to go flying to the ground. Izuku took the hit in stride and kept his eyes down on the ground where they belonged and apologized to Tomura like he should.

But then Hiryu returned a punch on Izuku’s behalf.

This punch set off a fuse in Tomura like he was made of dynamite.

Izuku had never seen such fury twist inside of Tomura’s eyes so *fast*. It was like Hiryu had unleashed a new unfound trigger inside of Tomura, and because of this Hiryu didn’t stand a chance. Hiryu was beaten to a bloodied pulp on the stone ground within a matter of minutes.

Punch after punch rained down on Hiryu until he was barely conscious.

The other four members of their team had turned away from the bloody scene, but Izuku could only take so much.

The hair on his skin rose tall in fear because this time was different. It wasn’t a quick slap or punch to show dominance—Tomura was going too far and only gaining speed. The sickening sound of bone crunching to tiny bits made Izuku nearly hurl.

Before Izuku could stop himself, he flung his small body between them, using himself as a shield.

Izuku had braced himself to take the next bloodied punch—but it never came.

He peered over his shoulder and five sets of eyes were staring wide at him. Four were staring in disbelief and one in pure, cold rage.

Tomura lowered his fist and gritted his teeth. “Izuku. Move.”

Hiryu groaned, coughing up blood.

“It’s my fault,” Izuku said sternly, not daring to look directly into Tomura’s eyes. “I was the one who was seen. I will take the punishment.”

“I was going to punish you *anyways*.” Tomura’s mouth pulled into a frown. “Hiryu needs to learn his place once and for all. I’m sick of his shit. Word is starting to get around that Hiryu refuses to follow my command and now Nine is questioning *my* leadership abilities.”

“Then let me take Hiryu’s punishment too.”

Aoyama gawked at him like he had grown a third eye, and Himiko slyly smirked at the thought of Izuku taking an extra beating. Jin sighed softly in sync with Ibara who shook her head at him. Hiryu weakly lifted himself off the ground. His face was swollen and his lip was split in several places.

Tomura eyed Hiryu like he was dirt and turned his deadly gaze back onto Izuku.

“If that’s what you want then *fine*,” Tomura agreed icily. “The moment we get back, be ready.”

Tomura walked away, signaling for the others to follow him and Izuku was left alone to gather Hiryu.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Tomura made good on his promise the second they were alone in their suite.

Izuku was so severely beaten he could barely breathe by the end. This punishment was harsher than usual and Izuku almost cried but he knew he couldn’t. Each hit with the sharp side of Tomura’s belt held so much force that Izuku couldn’t stop the small yelps that escaped from between his gritted teeth.

Tomura was getting stronger and he knew how to harness his new found power ruthlessly.

“You care too much about Hiryu,” Tomura spat distastefully at the end. “The only person you should care that much for is *me*, especially after all I’ve done for you. See what he made me do to you?”

Izuku nodded weakly.

“Do you really think Hiryu cares for you as much as me, Izuku?” Tomura asked.

Izuku shook his head. “No, I don’t think he cares for me as much as you.”

“Then *show it*.”

Tomura threw the bloodied belt down the laundry shoot and squatted to Izuku’s kneeled position on the ground. Izuku kept his eyes trained on the floor until Tomura’s fingers caught his chin and raised his head. Their eyes met and Izuku could feel the control radiating from his brother’s blood colored eyes.

“Listen to me carefully,” Tomura commanded strongly. “Hiryu is *selfish*. He jeopardizes this team. He jeopardizes *you*. He would *abandon* you in an instant if ever given the chance. I would *never* do that to you. From now on, you don’t need to take his punishments for him because he would never take them for you. Do you understand?”

Izuku didn’t think that was true, but he nodded to appease Tomura. Hiryu would never abandon him, they were family—he said so himself.

“Go sleep in Hiryu’s suite tonight,” Tomura instructed. “I want him to look at how badly he got you beat when it could have been a simple slap. Make sure to show him each and every single mark. I want him to know just how much it *hurts*.”

Izuku stumbled upright and his vision crossed.

The marks on his skin felt like a thousand burning fingernails clawing into him. Izuku used all his mental willpower to not faint from pain. Tediously, Izuku gathered a select few of his belongings and walked out of their room with his head down. The door shut loudly behind him with a bang and Izuku had to stand there in the hallways for a moment to catch his breath.

When he finally lifted his gaze, ice ran down his spine.

Himiko was leaning on the opposite side of the hall with a sick, twisted smirk.

“I think that’s the best beating I’ve heard you get,” Himiko hummed delightfully. “You were *so close* to crying like you used to. It makes me wonder what will *actually* get you crying again. Y’know I miss that sound so much.”

Her razor sharp grin made Izuku’s stomach turn. However, he knew she was the *one* person he could never show an inkling of weakness with.

He stared her deep in the eyes and bowed without breaking eye contact.

“Goodnight, Himiko.”

He walked away with his head high, forcing himself not to limp.

Izuku barreled into Hiryu's suite, furious. He didn't bother to knock and Hiryu glared at him out of the corner of his eye when Izuku threw down his bag next to the heap of dirty laundry.

"What is wrong with you?!" Izuku chastised in Korean.

Hiryu rolled his eyes. "You didn't need to take a beating for me—"

"And *you* didn't need to punch him for *me*!" Izuku harshly whispered. "I told you to keep your head down and go along with what he does! Do you want to die?!"

"I'm *sorry* we were not all trained to be Tomura's lap dog, Izuku," Hiryu jabbed sarcastically. "You may be alright with him treating you like property but I'm not."

"We *are* property." Izuku's nostrils flared. Izuku's hand shot out and grabbed Hiryu's trigger finger. He forced Hiryu to stare at the black ink that was permanently imprinted on his skin. "Look at it! This is our life and we can't change it! Property is what we are Hiryu and the sooner you accept that the better."

Hiryu stepped back as if the words burned.

"If you believe that then you're not who I thought you were." Hiryu brought his voice to a challenging low. "What about all the thoughts you have about love, Izuku? *Hah*? What about your *Kacchan*—"

"—He's dead, Hiryu!" Izuku's shot back. "But you're here and I can't lose you too to doing stupid antics like provoking Tomura. He will *kill* you—and so will Nine if he ever finds out about Kanna." Izuku's breath hitched as Hiryu's and Kacchan's faces blended in his mind. "I can't lose you too, hyung. *Please*."

Hiryu's eyes melted from disappointment to blankness.

"Please…Hiryu," Izuku begged. "Don't get yourself killed."

"…Fine," Hiryu muttered. "I'll try not to."

Izuku could tell it was a simple topic switch. This wasn't over, but the conversation was.

They settled down to sleep in silence, no more words exchanged. Izuku patched his own wounds and Hiryu carefully studied him the whole time. Pain twitched on Hiryu's brow as he looked at the layered bruises on Izuku's skin. Old ones were decorated with fresh new ones and on top of all of it were gashes from the belt Tomura used on Izuku's bare skin.

Hiryu laid down in his bed and Izuku took the floor with a spare pillow and blanket. He shuffled the tiny hill of dirty laundry out of his way and sighed. Hiryu was so messy in more than one way.

"Do you hate Tomura even a little for what he does to you?" Hiryu asked in the middle of the night.

It was the first time Hiryu verbally acknowledged Izuku's beatings.

“No,” Izuku answered honestly. “Tomura always has my best interest in mind, despite what you think. Tomura cares about me like you do. You two just show it differently.”

Hiryu grew silent once more.

He shifted in his bed and then he spoke again. “Izuku, can you do me a favor tomorrow after your solo assignment?”

“Of course,” Izuku agreed tiredly. “What is it?”

“Can you buy that potted plant for me? I want to give it to Kanna tomorrow.”



Izuku didn’t think twice about Hiryu’s request. It was a bit out of nowhere, but maybe it was Hiryu’s way of easing them back into an inkling of normalcy.

Izuku took his time after work picking out a nice plant. He chose a tiny green one with white rimmed leaves. The store owner told him it required a lot of care, and to be mindful to not place it directly in the sun. Izuku nodded, and thought it represented Kanna and Hiryu’s love for each other.

Pretty, but fragile.

He walked home in the busy streets of Tokyo with a red scarf wrapped around his neck. He shivered slightly and zipped up his yellow fleece. The winter winds had blown harshly this evening, bringing with them the change of the seasons. Izuku tried his best to protect the flimsy plant in his arms from being mangled too much as he traveled through the thick crowds.

When Izuku made it home that evening, he went straight for Hiryu’s suite.

He knocked once, knowing it would be ignored. Then he knocked again knowing Hiryu would finally get up with a swing of his legs and come to greet him.

However, nothing occurred.

Izuku furrowed his brow and knocked again. He was met with silence once more.

Izuku opened the door to reveal a dark suite.

“Hiryu?” Izuku called softly.

Silence.

He glanced over at the golden clock mounted on Hiryu’s living room wall. It was nearly 21:00.

Hiryu would have told him if he was going somewhere. And Hiryu would have *definitely* told him if he was potentially going to be out late with Kanna so Izuku could lie and say they

were together.

Izuku checked his digital watch for any missed notifications about assignments. Dread sank to the bottom of his stomach like heavy lead as he scrolled and scrolled. He double clicked emails and texts to find nothing new.

Hiryu was assigned nothing for the day. It was his rest day.

Izuku walked into Hiryu's bedroom and put the tiny plant on the sleek black desk. He stared around at the space and recognized it was clean in an oddly empty way. Items on the dresser were missing and the king sized bed was made stiffly. The usual messiness was absent.

At the exact moment the wind rattled the windows, Izuku noticed the usual heap of dirty clothes in the middle of the floor wasn't there.

Izuku wearily glanced at Hiryu's closet and he opened it.

It was empty.

ᔓᔓᔓ

The night of Hiryu's disappearance Izuku didn't speak a word.

Izuku struggled to wrap his mind around the concept, yet it was true. Hiryu waltzed out of the academy without so much as a goodbye. Hell, he even sent Izuku on a fool's errand just so he wasn't there to stop him when he did.

Izuku's heart twisted. This stung him right in his open wound of abandonment.

Somehow, yet again, Tomura had been right.

Izuku didn't sleep an ounce. By the next morning, he had felt all the warmth leave his body once more and nothingness coursed through his veins like he was just a shell of a human. The sunrise that morning felt hallow. Such beautiful colors spilling into the room for a soon to be bleak day.

It didn't take too long for others to notice the emptied out room. When Hiryu failed to report to the debrief for their next assignment that morning, it took all but two minutes for Tomura to march straight into Hiryu's room only to find all his clothes gone.

Tomura immediately went to Nine.

ᔓᔓᔓ

That afternoon, the whispers between The Viper Seven were strong. They sat in a private debriefing room all around an oval table.

Nine had made it clear not to let Hiryu's disappearance be known to *anyone* else. It would show a weak spot in their institution and give an illusion of choice.

“When they find him they’re going to kill him.” Jin snickered quietly. “No one simply *leaves*. How absurd is that?”

“I think they’ll torture him first before they kill him,” Himiko mused. She lazily spun a knife in her hand. “I hope they take volunteers. I always wanted to try my hand at torturing one of our own.”

She shot Izuku a blood thirsty gaze and Izuku ignored her.

“I hope they let him repent,” Ibara said sadly for Hiryu. “He’s a good asset with a perfect kill streak. It would be such a waste to let so many years of money and training go down the drain for a little bit of defect. Maybe he was fussy about not being chosen as the leader of the unit.”

“I agree with Ibara,” Aoyama said. His head was in his hands, stressed. “Hiryu has been top of his class for so long I doubt they will *kill* him. If anything, they might re-train him to be the leader of another squad since this one isn’t working for him. Then maybe execute him if that doesn’t work out as well because it would show his defect goes deeper than we thought.”

Izuku and Tomura both stayed silent. The casual debate about Hiryu’s life was unsettling to Izuku. However, Tomura was calm like he knew a secret.

Izuku cut his eyes to his Big Brother.

Tomura cut his eye back at him in a split second.

Izuku could see sadistic glee brewing at the bottom of that frigid stare.

ᔓᔓᔓ

That night at exactly 00:07, Izuku was abruptly woken up by Ibara, Jin, Himiko and Aoyama. They had barged into his suite and shook him awake so harshly Izuku briefly mistook it for an earthquake in his half sleep daze.

“Izuku!” Aoyama harshly whispered. “Get up! Tomura found Hiryu!”

Izuku was wide awake in a second.

He rushed downstairs with his squad with Ibara leading the way. Izuku’s heart was beating faster than it ever had before. He was scared if they would be met with a warm body or a cold corpse.

Ibara turned to a small door that only a select few had access to. She held up her watch to the scanner and an approving chime echoed out. Izuku looked behind him to make sure no one else saw them because this back way was a secret. It was only for The Viper Seven, Nine and Ms. Nagant.

They descended down a long staircase until they reached an elevator that took them even deeper inside the belly of their compound. When the elevator doors slid open, Nine and Ms.

Nagant were already there waiting in front of a freshly painted black, metal door.

The door scraped open and in walked Tomura from the outside world.

He was dressed in all black with stealth gear, and his hair was loosely fallen from its bun. His scar looked extra agitated, and his eyes seemed satiated like a beast that had finally been fed. Blood was splattered across his face and clothes while being caked into his brass knuckles.

He looks like hell, Izuku thought surprised.

There were clearly gashes on the patches of skin that showed on Tomura's shins and his breathing was careful as if he had a bruised lung.

But in his triumphant right hand was a fist full of ink black hair—*Hiryu*.

Hiryu was half conscious, both eyes black and bruised. The rest of his body was limp as Tomura dragged him in by his hair. If Tomura looked badly beaten, Hiryu looked close to death. It was clear Hiryu fought tooth and nail not to come back, but Tomura was a demon that was unmatched in blood lust.

Izuku wondered if there was anyone else alive who could rival just how vicious Tomura was.

Tomura unceremoniously threw Hiryu into the middle of the circle of vipers.

Nine walked forward and stepped directly on Hiryu's face with his shiny, perfect leather shoe. Hiryu sobbed and tried to turn away but was pinned down forcefully by the full weight of Nine's body. The purple in Nine's eyes felt like it became more vibrant with hate as he spoke his next words.

"*Basement*," Nine spat. "Solitary confinement for one month with full punishment for ten hours a day."

Himiko flinched at that.

Jin helped Ibara gather a weeping Hiryu who weakly struggled against them. He screamed each second as he was forcefully dragged to the elevator that no doubt led to the depths of hell. Izuku kept his emotionless mask tight as he watched them enter through the steel doors.

When the doors shut, it felt like Hiryu was being transported to the deepest circle of hell.

How did they find him so fast? Izuku wondered.

It hadn't even been a full twenty four hours between now and when everyone else found out Hiryu was missing. Izuku carefully studied Nine then directed his gaze to Tomura who was already boring his eyes into Izuku's skull.

Ominousness foreboding slipped down Izuku's nerves as they held eye contact.

He understood then that they could never leave.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Hiryu was kept in the basement for two months, not one.

The word from Himiko was that they were torturing him beyond normal regulations. They were picking him a part trying to find out what triggered him to run away after he had been the perfect killing weapon.

But they were unable to.

Izuku knew not even six months of torture would cause Hiryu to give up Kanna's name and admit he had crossed their one, deeply forbidden rule. Hiryu loved Kanna too much, and because of that Hiryu would condemn himself to a lifetime of pain.

Eventually Nine concluded that Hiryu's running away was a momentary state of psychosis.

On the last day of punishment, Hiryu seemed like nothing more than a broken doll.

The two months in the basement were a sure, but slow descent into insanity. Hiryu's once sleek, perfect hair had lost its shine and filled with built up dandruff. The bags under his eyes were red with lack of sleep and his nose had been broken so much it took an entirely different shape. This wasn't the same Hiryu.

Hiryu didn't meet anyone's eyes or speak once he was returned.

Izuku was unsure of what to say or do.

But at the end of the day, Izuku was thankful Hiryu was alive.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Later that night, Izuku snuck away from Tomura to go visit Hiryu in his suite. He walked down the empty halls in the dead of night and knocked quietly.

"Hiryu?" Izuku whispered.

He pushed open the door with care.

His eyes strained looking into the blackness of Hiryu's room.

Scratch. Scratch.

A string of sobs breached Izuku's ears as he crept forward into the darkness. Eeriness swallowed him whole as he walked in further, surprised by the crunch of glass underneath his shoes.

Izuku halted when he found a figure hunched over in the corner of the living room. It was Hiryu, with his back facing him in the darkest corner of the room. Hiryu's hair was wild and

messy, spilling down his back—and Izuku audibly gasped when he saw what the flesh on Hiryu's spine looked like.

The marks on Hiryu's skin were so deep they could be mistaken for knife gashes. At first Izuku thought they were, but the closer he grew he could see they were self-inflicted fingernail marks. Hiryu had dug so deep into his skin he had drawn inordinate amounts of blood. Hiryu's body was convulsing as he kept scratching and *scratching* as if searching for something.

"Hyung—" Izuku changed over to their shared language. He reached a hand out. "Stop, you're hurting yourself—"

"Get out," Hiryu harshly snapped back in Japanese. He rejected the language switch and it stung like a slap.

Hiryu's bloodshot eyes glared from over his shoulder like a wounded creature.

Izuku's feet didn't move. His eyes remained locked on the crimson blood oozing down Hiryu's back and onto the carpet. The beige surface material around Hiryu had soaked up large amounts of blood and the crimson color was spreading fast like a deadly infection.

Izuku's heart clenched with the need to help.

"I said leave!" Hiryu nearly screamed.

Hiryu's broken voice boomed so loud it startled Izuku. It was similar to rolling thunder that was crackling over and over like the gods above were weeping. It was painfully broken, and splintered at all ends of his words. It was heartbreak.

Izuku began to walk away when he knew he was no longer welcomed. Hiryu sobbed so violently as if he had lost something vital. All Izuku wanted to do was hug him—but he knew he couldn't. His back hit the door and he lowered his head.

He'd talk to Hiryu another time when this all blew over.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku woke the next morning to an empty suite. Tomura was up and gone like usual if they didn't have shared scheduled agendas. Izuku himself didn't have any assignments today, and originally planned on spending the day shopping at the mall with Ibara later in the afternoon.

However, the first thing on his mind was Hiryu. Izuku couldn't shake that last, bloodshot gaze they shared. It was haunting him like nails on a chalkboard and he needed to remedy their relationship somehow.

Eventually Izuku wandered to Hiryu's hallway once he showered and dressed. As he walked around the corner, he anticipated Hiryu to still be moody and silent.

He began to brainstorm things that would help Hiryu cheer up. Like maybe reminding him of how good they had it.

To Izuku, life at The Academy wasn't *that* bad.

They were protected from the cruelties of the outside world in exchange for exterminating a couple of pests.

They had extravagant dinners every night. Expensive suites, porcelain tubs, and were paid commission for every assignment to blow on whatever they liked. Jin had an extensive collection of motorcycles. Tomura tattooed his skin with thousands of dollars worth of ink. Even Aoyama had the most up to date technology that made him foam at the mouth.

They could see movies, drive cars and wander Tokyo now that they were the top vipers. They took trips on their off weeks to places like Paris or sometimes just stayed at home in the middle of the most expensive neighborhood in Tokyo.

Nine doted on their every whim now that they were The Viper Seven.

Izuku began daydreaming about how this whole incident would be like a bad toothache from the past. Soon he and Hiryu would resume their usual rooftop hangouts and everything would be as it was.

Then that daydream was snapped in two when Izuku arrived at Hiryu's room.

Everything was in chaos.

Hoards of his viper siblings were gathered around, whispering and staring. Dozens of fingers were pointed at the puddle of blood that was seeping out from the mouth of the door. Adrenaline caused Izuku to see double at the sight of bright red. Bright red was never good. Izuku staggered forward, pushing through all the warm bodies huddled together.

Frantically, Izuku's eyes darted all around until he broke free to stand in the front of the crowd.

He came to a halt in front of Hiryu's wide open suite.

Every item in the suite he could see was demolished. The golden clock was shattered. The kitchen chairs were broken into bits and sheets from the bed were torn off and ripped to frayed fragments.

Standing in the wake of the aftermath was Tomura. He was off to the side, leaning on the wall next to the open window. His brows were pinched together and his arms were crossed.

For the first time in Izuku's life his big brother seemed *defeated*.

Next to Tomura was Ms. Nagant. Her face was distorted as if she swallowed a swarm of bees.

And finally, Nine was standing in the middle of the living room. He juxtaposed the brokenness of the scene with his put together outfit. His black dress shoes stood on top of

bloodied shards of glass and one of his hands was tucked into his black slacks.

His gaze was locked on his other hand.

Izuku followed his stare to see what he was holding. Inside of Nine's gloved hand was a tiny scrap that Izuku couldn't make out. He squinted his eyes to see it was small, in the shape of a square and covered in a thin layer of blood.

Nine's face melted into fury and he crushed the object in his fist.



3 years before The Incident

Two years without Hiryu was two years Izuku bitterly hoped he was safe and happy.

He had seen this before in the romance book he used to read when he was younger: *the one who got away*. That's exactly what Hiryu was to Izuku, and the impact his missing brother had was irreversible.

Without Hiryu, Izuku smiled less and laughed sparsely. In Hiryu's wake were only residual traces of emptiness.

Once again, Izuku had been left behind by someone he trusted. He knew he and Hiryu never talked about running away together like him and Kacchan had, but his brain still felt slighted all the same. Only this time, he didn't cry.

Izuku however had a secret notion brewing in him that was stirred to life in Hiryu's absence: the desire to be far away from here. Izuku had locked away all feelings of romance, love, and yearning for a normal life. He buried those concepts because he was convinced that was unachievable for someone like him.

But Hiryu was tangible proof that notion was *wrong*.

Hiryu risked everything to be with the person he *loved*, and he had successfully gotten *out*.

Izuku never said it out loud, but in the back of his mind his old self was resurfacing. His hands itched for the hidden romance novel and the old violin. He ached to indulge himself in the ideas of love and romance.

Hiryu was so lucky.

Izuku was seventeen now, and he was securely tucked underneath Tomura's wing. Without Hiryu working as a counter force against Tomura, Tomura bloomed like poison in the veins.

The ice in Tomura's heart consumed him entirely and now there was no one to question his methods. The Viper Seven's name never changed to The Viper Six because no one besides their squad, Nine, and Ms. Nagant knew that Hiryu had escaped for good.

As far as others knew, Hiryu was on a long term mission embedded in another country as a permanent spy for Tokyo's Governor. But in private, they all knew what really happened and no one dared to mention Hiryu for two years.

That was, until now.

They were all currently sitting around at a private dinner with Nine. Nine was placed at the head of the white marble table, eating a large steak off a gold plate with golden cutlery. On his right hand side was Tomura, possessing silver plates and cutlery. Then to Tomura's right was Izuku.

Everyone else had regular, unimportant metal utensils. Izuku never paid it any mind, but after heeding what Hiryu said, Izuku could see Tomura secretly glance at Nine's golden plate with envy every time they had dinner.

Everyone ate expensive steaks with casual conversation floating around the table. The pitter patter of rain against the giant window beside them provided ambiance.

Then Nine spoke up.

"We found 102."

Everyone stopped eating.

Izuku's eyes widened and his stomach flipped. He glanced around and noticed everyone was surprised except Aoyama.

"Where?" Jin asked eagerly.

Nine looked at Aoyama as he continued to eat his rare steak.

"He slipped up," Aoyama answered for Nine. "During a mission, one of the lower ranked Vipers saw him down south. He got a nose job and plastic surgery work to change his features, but he took his glove off to type a text and his tattoo on his mark was revealed. That Viper, who *didn't* know Hiryu was missing, walked straight up to him and asked him how his spy mission had been going. Hiryu got spooked and ran away."

Izuku closed his eyes and lowered his head in dread.

Oh, *Hiryu*.

"This situation needs to be handled immediately and quietly," Nine said. He wiped the corners of his mouth with the expensive napkin and then clasped his hands calmly. "I did my research and confirmed he's been working with an agency that also deals with assassinations, using a fake surname."

Izuku's heart twisted as his stomach grew more and more nauseated.

"Luckily for us, 215 hacked 102's current agency's system without being detected once I gave him the information I found," Nine praised slightly. "102 is going across seas tomorrow

on a lowly bodyguard assignment."

Ibara tilted her head. "What an odd choice to do after leaving us."

"Agreed," Nine said. His calculating eyes then scanned the table. "Now, who wants to be the one to kill 102?"

Izuku's head whipped up.

Kill? They weren't even going to bring him in?

As Izuku had that split second thought, he was the only one not to raise his hand immediately.

Nine's eyes cut to Izuku, as everyone else started begging for the chance.

Izuku's skin swarmed with heat.

He slowly raised his hand as if he had just heard what was said. It felt so goddamn *wrong* but Izuku kept his hand raised. He prayed with every fiber that Nine picked *any* of the other five maniacs at this table to do this deed.

"Oh! *Oh*! Choose me!" Himiko pleaded. She grinned with all her teeth and waved her hand a bit. "I would love the chance to gut him. I've been perfecting new torture techniques and I would make sure he felt every ounce of pain."

"Or send me," Jin cut in. "I would be delighted to end his life for you. He's disrespected the viper name far too many times."

"I have the same sentiment as Jin," Ibara added.

Izuku stayed silent, absolutely horrified by all his siblings for the first time in a while. How could they all be so nonchalant about killing one of their *own*? They *grew up* with Hiryu.

Nine strummed his fingers on the marble surface without uttering a word.

"Interesting," Nine said. It didn't sound good. "Everyone but 217 leave."

Everyone deflated a bit, sad not to be chosen. Himiko shot him a glare, and Jin groaned out loud. The colorful bunch of killers walked out the room—well. All but one.

Everyone left except Tomura.

Izuku was surprised that Tomura didn't immediately jump at Nine's command. When Izuku turned his head to his brother beside him, Tomura was actually regarding him with a level of pity.

"117, I asked that you leave 217 and I alone for a while," Nine repeated himself. "Did you not hear me?" A small crease in his eyebrow appeared from agitation.

“I did,” Tomura said calmly. He clasped his hands on the table as if he owned it. “I would like to request to be present for this conversation.”

“*Why*?” Nine questioned unkindly. The crease in his brow grew bigger.

“Because 217 is…” Tomura stole a quick glance to Izuku then cleared his throat. “Because *I* would like to be the one to execute 102, sir. It would bring me great joy considering all the trouble he’s given me in the past.”

“117—leave.”

“But sir—”

“I said *leave*.” Nine finally snapped. His mouth finally pulled into a frown.

Tomura had pushed Nine’s boundaries and tested a line of authority no one else had dared to before.

Izuku held his breath while Tomura became withdrawn. Nine huffed slightly and brushed his hair out of his face. When Nine turned his attention on Izuku, he missed the deep, envy filled glare Tomura gave the backside of his head.

But Izuku saw it and it sent a new type of chill down his spine.

Tomura then cut his eyes to Izuku as if he *wanted* Izuku to see the glare he gave Nine. Then Tomura exited the lavish dining hall, closing the door softly.

Nine reached below his seat to his briefcase, pulled out a shiny red folder that held an emblem of their twin snakes. He stood up from his chair, red folder in hand, and walked towards the large window in the room that overlooked the city of Tokyo. He motioned fluidly with his hand for Izuku to follow.

Izuku proceeded with caution and stood side by side with Nine.

They gazed down at the neon city lights and the rain that was sprinkling down on their hometown. Some lights flickered, others flashed brightly. The city limits stretched beyond the horizon like an endless sea.

“217. Do you know how animals are domesticated?” Nine asked without looking at him.

“A bit,” Izuku answered. He kept his eyes trained on the pouring rain.

“It’s quite fascinating honestly.” Nine spoke casually and took a posture as if they were friends. “Handlers breed for kindness towards humans and cull the ones that are vicious. They pluck and *pluck*, breeding the weak, sappy animals over and over until it gives them the personality they want: a dumb, kind animal that dotes on their every whim.”

Nine laid a heavy hand on Izuku’s shoulder.

Izuku turned his head to look at Nine and wanted to flinch.

Nine's lavender eyes were burning right into his.

"Want to know why that's fascinating?" Nine asked.

Izuku nodded as if he had a choice.

"Because it shows that kindness is genetic as is viciousness in animals, and aren't we all animals? Walking, talking, breathing *filthy* animals. If it's possible to weed out and breed for kindness, then the reverse can be true, can it not?"

"Yes, sir," Izuku whispered.

Nine's hand on his shoulder gripped him painfully. Quickly, Izuku wanted Tomura to be here —Nine would never touch him in front of Tomura Izuku noted now.

"As you can see I am in the business of killing off the weak, kind ones. I only want the vicious ones—so. Tell me, Izuku: are you vicious or are you weak?"

Nine held out the folder for him to take.

Izuku could feel the heavy weight of it before he touched it. He didn't want this, every nerve in his body was on fire, rejecting the concept of what he had just been chosen to carry out. But Izuku knew that Nine was threatening him, not lecturing him.

Izuku had two paths laid plainly in front of him: kill or be killed. And unfortunately, he was only alive to survive.

Defeat settled into Izuku's core as he took the folder and the paper scorched his fingertips.

Nine approvingly nodded at him with a smile as fake and shiny as plastic.

"Glad to see you're smart. You leave for Vienna in an hour."

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku was shipped in a tiny, private plane to Vienna, Austria.

The flight was a full fourteen hours long and it gave him time to prep how he would execute this assignment.

This situation was Izuku's greatest fear and *exactly* what Tomura had been warning him about for years. Hiryu had tested their rules in the name of love and now love was going to be the reason Hiryu's body would become food for worms in the cold ground.

Half way through the plane ride, Izuku tossed and turned in the uncomfortable cabin bed.

The suffocating dread in his gut was growing more and more overpowering. He *really* didn't want to do this, and this was the first mission that he couldn't ignore who was inside the red folder.

He had made it this far by avoiding humanizing his targets. They were marks. Prey. Ants. Anything *but* human.

But now, he couldn't trick himself into this kill. Izuku knew this mark almost better than he knew himself and his empathy was sitting directly on the surface of this case.

Izuku scanned through Hiryu's red folder in the dead of night. He wanted to see how much information there was exactly—and his heart dropped further and further with every file.

Everything was in here.

Aoyama truly was impeccable at hacking and tracking. He found a list of fake names and IDs Hiryu used. The plastic surgeon who reconstructed his face. The apartments he had been bouncing around in for the last two years.

But worst of all—Kanna's picture was stapled on the bottom of page six. She was smiling so happily in the photograph that was clearly taken from a distance.

Seeing Kanna's face again made Izuku briefly consider letting Hiryu live. Maybe he could help Hiryu disappear a third time? But Izuku was too weary of how watchful the eyes of The Academy were. No Viper left so simply. Hiryu had now failed at this *twice*.

No matter where Hiryu went, Izuku knew his brother would be found over and over again by the bloodthirsty snakes they called family. Izuku recounted how *desperate* to kill Hiryu both Himiko and Jin were. They probably would drag out his death over multiple days and slash away at the same spots until he was mutilated beyond recognition.

At that, Izuku found peaceful resolve and closed his eyes to sleep.

At least out of the six possible people who could be assigned to kill Hiryu, Izuku knew he would be the most gracious.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku landed in Vienna the day before Hiryu was supposed to arrive.

It had been raining in Vienna and the sidewalks were glossy with puddles of rain. Izuku used a bright yellow umbrella as he discreetly scouted out the area. He had memorized the map of the lavish building and its surroundings on the plane. Now, he was overlaying it in his mind to carefully execute his mercy kill.

Hiryu's current assignment was to protect an Austrian diplomat. Hiryu had two other partners on this assignment. Good to know. Izuku didn't bother sinking too much interest in those details in case things went south and he had to exterminate those guys too. He could handle knowing details on Hiryu because he already did—but he couldn't do strangers.

In hindsight, Izuku wished he had bothered to memorize the photos of the partners.

Maybe then he wouldn't have been so caught off guard.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When the next day arrived, Izuku masked his emotions.

A mercy kill.

This was a mercy kill, he repeated to himself as he loaded his gun. He snapped on the silencer with a stone, cold gaze. He strapped himself with sharp knives that were easily accessible. Then he combed his hair to look as nice as possible.

He stared at his reflection in the mirror before carefully unfolding the venue's waiter uniform. It was a deep red color made of silky material and the neckline plunged down. Izuku then carefully put on the ruby earrings Tomura had picked out for him one time in Barcelona. Izuku took in a deep, steadying breath as he shrugged on a black trenchcoat.

The moment was here and the red folder had suggested one of two ways to kill Hiryu.

The first approach, poison. Quick, easy, but unfortunately public.

The details suggested that Izuku slip their fail safe poison in Hiryu's drink as he walked by disguised as a waiter. Because Hiryu had been missing for so long, his poison tolerance was likely gone. Mithridatism only worked if you did it every day. And the likelihood Hiryu had hundreds of poisons to keep his tolerance up like they did was close to zero.

Cons of this approach was that there would potentially be a scene in that type of crowd. Izuku would have to be ready to exit quickly and *fast*. Plus, there was the potential of him being seen fleeing.

The second option was a bit more hands on but far more discreet.

Hiryu and one of his partners were scheduled for rooftop duty at the venue. The diplomats were going to be meeting at the sixth floor at the venue. The rooftop Hiryu would be stationed at would give a perfect view inside to the diplomat in case things became sticky.

Unfortunately, no other buildings in the area would give a perfect view to Hiryu. A close kill would be needed. Izuku would have to enter the roof top and then execute Hiryu and whoever else was there.

Izuku decided on the first option.

He didn't want to be in the room when Hiryu died, Izuku concluded.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku walked into the room that smelled like the filthy rich.

Various perfumes and colognes intermingled into each other like an exotic dance. The chandeliers above twinkled from diamonds and all around was gold lining and red velvet fabric.

Izuku walked into the room in his trench coat, then made his way to the service area where he discreetly discarded his coat. He blended quickly with the other waiters, taking a tray in the busy room. He walked around slowly, careful not to draw attention as he quickly scanned the room for his run away brother.

Then he saw Hiryu from a distance.

Hiryu looked different.

His cheeks were hollow, and his nose no longer had that crooked slant to it that Izuku used to admire. His forehead was shorter and his lips were now oddly thin. But his *eyes* were still inky and cold in a way only the Obsidian Viper could possess.

The table Hiryu was sitting at was egregiously long and full of what seemed to be useless conversation. His brother had his black eyes trained on the front door while the diplomat chatted with other politicians in the middle of the long table. Who Izuku presumed to be the other two bodyguards were dressed in all black tuxedos, closely watching the other two doors from the other far end of the table.

Izuku shifted himself fully out of Hiryu's line of vision.

He knew Hiryu would never take his eye off that entrance door. He was too well trained.

A dark shadow cast itself over Izuku's eyes as he turned on his kill switch.

He pulled a dissolvable poison bead from his pocket, ready to slip it in the drink as he walked by. He strolled up to the table, eyes zoned in on the sapphire drink Hiryu had beside him.

Izuku quickly assessed the other people on the opposite end of the long table to make sure no one was paying close attention to him.

But he froze.

Blazing, crimson eyes met his and time stood still.

Izuku halted walking, feeling a crazed sense of whiplash slap him across the face. His breath hitched in his throat and he could feel his heart skip a needed beat. The other teen held eye contact right back, looking equally as awe-struck. The stranger slightly cocked his head and Izuku could feel his face flush for the first time with a forgotten emotion.

This was single-handedly the most handsome person Izuku had ever laid eyes on.

His face was angled yet gentle and the portions of his features were eerily perfect. From his symmetrical eyebrows to his high cheekbones, it was almost as if the universe was fated to make someone as stunning as him. This guy was an inevitable type of handsome, Izuku concluded.

But what was most off putting was his red-orange eyes and ash blond hair.

That combination made Izuku feel like he had been thrown off a moving train because this other teen looked like—

—*Kacchan*.

Izuku gaped like a fish until the handsome teen smirked.

Shit. Izuku quickly pulled it together once he realized he was staring. *Why does he remind me so much of Kacchan?*

It's just the hair and eyes, the reasonable part of his brain told him. *Red eyes are common. Think of Tomura. Blond hair is also common. Think of Aoyama, Himiko and Jin. There's no logic behind the possibility of it being him in Austria halfway across the world after ten years.*

With that, Izuku convinced himself that seeing someone with blond hair and red eyes shouldn't shock him as much as it just did—but it was *terrible* how much this guy looked exactly how Izuku envisioned the future version of Kacchan to be in his head.

He had a small fixation on that, he knew. The model on the cover of the romance book having blond hair and red eyes was the whole reason Izuku read it in the first place.

Izuku quickly stole a glance at Hiryu who was paying no attention. He was promptly grounded back in reality when he could feel the pressure of the poison tab in his palm.

An older man sitting next to the blond teen waved him over. "Are you our server? We've been sitting here forever!"

Izuku forcefully smiled and played his part of the waiter perfectly.

He had been compromised and needed to go along with the flow before Hiryu turned his head and this ended in a bloody shootout. Izuku found himself taking faux orders for half of the large table but when it came time to take the blond teen's order, Izuku could feel a tiny shift in his mood.

"Er, what is this called?" The blond teen asked curiously in bad German. Izuku soaked in his voice, it was deep and raspy. Izuku could tell it was only going to drop more the older he became. The blond gave a lopsided grin and scratched his cheek. "I, uh, don't speak German very well."

"Oh, it's *Käsespätzle*," Izuku replied in perfect German. "I think you said it nicely."

Hypnotizing red eyes peered up at him so curiously, studying his every move.

"Really?" The other teen asked. The crooked smile grew bigger.

"Yeah." Izuku smiled sweetly at how hard the other teen was trying at a new language. "You have to emphasize the syllable with your tongue to the roof of your mouth more."

The tiniest chuckle escaped the handsome stranger. He tried to pronounce the dish again and was *horrible*. Izuku bit back a snicker at how rough it was and the other teen marveled at Izuku's smile.

"Did I do it better this time?" The stranger teased.

Izuku genuinely laughed. "Not at all, but I understand you."

"Well. As long as you understand me, I'm alright then."

Izuku smiled at the extended grace.

The blond was not only unfairly gorgeous, but kind as well. Izuku was then pulled into taking other people's orders at this end of the table. Mostly drinks and a couple of desserts. He kept an eye on Hiryu in his peripheral vision. Luckily for him, Hiryu never bother to mind himself with what was happening at this far end of the table.

Hiryu sipped on his drink and Izuku felt the window closing for him to slip in the poison.

When Izuku was done scribbling on the note pad, he tried to walk away—but was stopped by a hand that reached to grab his elbow. The connection felt like electricity, and Izuku whirled around, surprised by the soft touch. The blond stranger also seemed surprised by himself. The stranger reeled back his hand, and quietly pressed it in his lap as if he needed help to control himself.

"Sorry," the stranger murmured, embarrassed. "I don't know what came over me."

"It's okay," Izuku replied quickly. The jolt of where the stranger had touched him lingered. "Did you need something?"

"I just wanted to ask…is it your first day on the job?" The blond asked dumbly.

"Um," Izuku didn't know what to say but the shining red eyes were pinning him in place, as if begging him not to go. "Yes, why do you ask?"

"You seem nervous. Not in a bad way but definitely nervous."

"I am a bit."

Not a lie. He had to kill someone he was close with tonight.

"Well, you're doing a great job." The blond smiled shyly. "I don't know if my opinion counts for anything since I am just a random guy, but I'll be sure to tell the others to give you a big tip for your first day."

Izuku laughed slightly at how absurdly kind this guy was. "Thank you, that's very sweet of you but you don't have to do that for me. Tips aren't customary here."

Izuku tried to take a step away again, but was gripped once more by that damn *voice*.

“But what if I *want* to do it for you?”

The blond’s gaze intensified. Izuku’s cheeks flamed up.

Sharp, embered colored eyes roamed all over his face. He could see the other teen’s body language shift. The blond leaned towards Izuku, and stared at him like he was the most beautiful thing he had seen.

“Th-Then I guess that’s fine.” Izuku stammered, fully blushing. “Thank you.”

The heat gathering under his collar was taking him off guard because he didn’t know what to do. He hadn’t been trained on how to react when a handsome blond flirted with him in bad German.

Izuku wearily stole a look at Hiryu.

Hiryu’s glass was empty now. The metaphorical window for his first option shut tight and locked. Izuku felt like kicking himself at how he had screwed up.

“I’ll be right back with your orders,” Izuku quickly said.

“Wait—what’s your name?” The blond asked but Izuku hurried out of there.

He practically ran away from the table, too fearful of staying there and getting caught. As Izuku retreated, he couldn’t help but glance over his shoulder. Saddened, red eyes were watching him go and it nearly looked like the blond wanted to chase him. The stranger waved goodbye at him, and Izuku gave an unwillingly sad half smile back.

Once he was clear of the building, Izuku mentally berated himself mentally over and over.

How did he let himself get that deeply distracted? All of this trouble was because he was entranced by the concept of someone even *slightly* resembling the boy from his past.

This will not happen again, Izuku lectured himself. *From now on, no more thinking of Kacchan on assignments.*

But he didn’t know that fateful meeting was the beginning of the end.

ɯɯɯ

Izuku was left with the final option to kill Hiryu.

He didn’t want to have to see his brother die up close, but they were in the business of doing things they had no desire to do.

Izuku sucked it up.

He did what Tomura trained him to do: he shut off his emotions. Izuku meditated himself to fall all the way into the bottom of his being. It was dark there. Cold and unwelcoming. It was the perfect viper den where the darkest side of him resided. He let the dark side of him slither

forward and grasp the wheel, and he himself sat at the bottom of his mind like he wasn't the one steering.

His perfectly trained killer took over and he became a shell of himself, feeling nothing.

Izuku was the Viridian Viper now.

He waited until he could see Hiryu and someone else walk across the street to a dark building. The pair went in through the back, and Izuku followed behind at the perfect pace. Not too close, not too far. Izuku picked the lock effortlessly and stealthily climbed up the metal staircase. He was light on his feet and the moment he reached the top floor, Izuku drew his gun.

The dark shadow overcasting his eyes returned—and this time it didn't waiver.

Izuku fluidly moved on the rooftop, blending with the shadows.

Before either man could see him, Izuku locked in on them and fired off four shots.

Two into Hiryu. Two into Hiryu's partner.

Izuku registered briefly that Hiryu's partner was actually the handsome blond from earlier. The only thing that crossed his thoughts while he was in the mindset of the Viridian Viper was: *Shame*. *What a waste of looks.*

Izuku bum rushed the blond teen because he knew Hiryu was slow to recover from being shot. Izuku elbowed the stranger in the throat to disorient him and in a twisted dance, quickly rounded to grab a hold of his arm. Izuku disarmed the other and in a flash, slammed the other teen to the ground with all his strength.

He could hear the other teen's skull crack against the concrete.

A rustle behind Izuku told him Hiryu was rebounding from the two gunshots. In the next moment, Izuku pulled his gun once more. He fired off two perfect shots in Hiryu's knee caps, shattering them. Hiryu folded on himself like a burning house collapsing inwards. The four bullet wounds in Hiryu bled and bled. Izuku followed the trail of pouring blood to stand over his runaway brother, eclipsing the light of the moon.

Hiryu's inky black eyes gazed up at him.

The split second of recognition flashed before Izuku could prevent it.

"Sorry, hyung," Izuku whispered in Korean.

"Please. No. *Izu*—"

The Viridian Viper pulled the trigger.

Silence.

Blood.

So much *blood*.

Izuku stared at the body beneath him and all the red that was pouring from it. Hiryu's eyes looked directly up at him and an ominous chill brought Izuku back to the front of his mind. He tried to stop it—but he began floating back into the driver's seat. Izuku tried to tear his eyes away from Hiryu's growing pale face—but he couldn't.

As Hiryu died in front of him, all their memories together flashed before Izuku's eyes.

He saw his brother who helped raise him. He saw the brother who was the top of his class. The brother who helped defend him against bullies when he was a kid. He saw the brother that helped him train and gave him pointers. He saw the brother that smoked with a crooked smile and held hands with his girlfriend in the park. He saw the brother that was in love.

And now, he saw that same brother bleeding out on a rooftop.

Izuku's heart squeezed and squeezed until something in him snapped with grief.

What have you done? The voice of empathy within him asked. *He loved you and you killed him.*

Izuku slumped.

He crouched down with the burden of murder laying heavy on his shoulders. He got a clear view of Hiryu now, and he knew this was the whole reason he didn't want to do this up close in the first place.

Hiryu's face still looked the same despite the plastic surgeries to Izuku. His eyes were uniquely Obsidian all the way up to his death and his hair was always neatly combed back.

When the final twitch went out of Hiryu's body, Izuku could see now he was squatting above the corpse of someone he used to deeply care for. Izuku held up his digital watch's face and clicked the side button to take a small picture for proof. Hiryu was dead, and he had done it.

Izuku closed Hiryu's eyelids sadly.

Ragged breathing brought Izuku back into the present.

He cut his eyes to the teen in front of him who was floundering on the dirty rooftop. Izuku held up his gun and pointed it directly at the blond. He felt a surprising twinge of pity when the blond stared at him. His stunning ember eyes were now bloodshot and he seemed to be in enormous pain.

"I'm sorry you had to see that," Izuku said sincerely. "It's nothing personal. You weren't my mark."

"I'll *kill* you for this."

Izuku raised a brow.

The other guy was gritting his teeth, unable to even *lift* himself off the ground. But his eyes were full of unchecked, blazing fury. Izuku could feel the hate from here, but it was stupidly pointless to him. The other's gun was out of reach and without proper medical attention Izuku was sure this guy would have Vienna marked on his death certificate.

"Huh? You're saying *you* are going to kill *me* when *I'm* the one with the gun on *you*?" Izuku asked slowly. He made sure to emphasize exactly what type of position this guy was in because maybe he didn't realize. Usually this was the part where people begged for their life. "You're a bit mouthy."

"Quit fucking *toying* with me!" The nameless guy snapped. "Why don't you just kill me already instead of fucking holding conversation?"

Izuku decided he was right and cocked his gun.

He held up his weapon and moved to pull the trigger—and immediately he was bombarded with the memory of Kacchan shivering on the bench in the snow with the soft sounds of violin in the background.

Izuku furrowed his brow at the inappropriate moment for such a memory.

He tried again to pull the trigger, but was once more greeted by another memory of Kacchan. This time he saw them together in the nook cuddled and reading comics.

He unwillingly halted.

Izuku told himself to simply *pull the damn trigger* but each time he attempted, his brain supplied him with memories from when he was a child. Trying to fire the gun felt like there was a string attached from the trigger to his heart and if he pulled too hard he might hurt himself in the process.

All he could see was Kacchan while staring at this stranger.

Izuku tried to shake himself out of it but soon the teen in front of him blended with the memory of the boy from his past. They perfectly overlapped with the same colored hair and eyes.

Then Izuku looked down at Hiryu's corpse at his feet.

That was a mistake.

His mind warped the imagery of his dead brother with the forgotten boy of his childhood. He saw Kacchan dead, bleeding out in the nook covered in old rags. Beneath him was Hiryu with his eyes rolled back and their blood mingled together horribly.

Tears pushed at Izuku's eyes for the first time in years.

His breathing stopped and he realized he had been emotionally compromised.

Everything began to tilt as the memories in his head leveled his whole being. Izuku was ambushed with memories of the violinist, Kanna, Kacchan, the nook, Hiryu, and *more*. It was all coming too fast, too potent, and far too much for Izuku to stop.

Izuku turned his head away from Hiryu's corpse and pointed his gun away from the blond.

Immediately all the memories stopped.

Shock echoed into Izuku's core.

What just happened?

Stunned, slowly Izuku stood up. The Viridian Viper side of him was long gone now, slithered safely away into the dark parts of his core. In its place stood the tiny boy he once was, hurting for Hiryu and Kacchan.

His inner child was spiteful and held bloodshot eyes. With all its neglected resentment, the younger version of himself caused all his pent up emotions to pound against his rib cage. They banged and banged with balled up fists, *demanding* to be let out.

Tears bursted from Izuku's eyes.

In an instant before the other teen could see, Izuku turned his back. The hot tears streamed down his face like a dam finally breaking and Izuku's throat tightened at an alarming tempo.

Izuku had to get away from this man.

"Please stay out of my way," Izuku whispered quietly before disappearing into the night.

Izuku couldn't think.

Hell, he couldn't breathe.

He boarded the private plane back to Tokyo with his whole world flipped upside down—and it was all because of one, single *blond*.

Once Izuku was alone in the plane's private cabin, his hands began to tremble. The tremors ached through his bones like earthquakes, splitting his heart into countless fractures. He tried to will himself to stop shaking but he *couldn't*. He tilted against the wall of the plane as he trembled and trembled until he slid down on the cold, hard floor.

Suddenly, from out of his eyes an endless stream of tears poured down like a hurricane. Izuku balled up his fists and choked on his bottled up emotions. His vision swayed with grieving thoughts of Hiryu and Kacchan melting in his mind. He mourned Kacchan. He mourned Hiryu. He had killed Hiryu for simply loving someone like he had in the past.

Izuku could feel the invisible string around his ring finger and that spot *burned* to be acknowledged.

Izuku pressed the heels of his palms into his eyes in an attempt to will all the unwanted tears back inside his skull. But they kept coming, and going, and Izuku sobbed like a child until his throat was sore.

"*Why*?" Izuku gasped desperately. He sobbed into his quivering palms. "Why did he have to die? Why did I have to be the one to kill him?"

He reeled back, and stared in horror at his shaking hands that were now coated in his tears. He was mortified at what he had done and what he *didn't* do.

He had successfully killed Hiryu and in the process Izuku let a *witness* live.

This was the first and *only* loose end Izuku had ever had.

When the seriousness of his screw up fully slammed Izuku, he grasped that he could *never* let anyone know what happened—*or worse*—what he discovered. Because Izuku had a bigger problem than a loose end—he had a mental block.

A giant, *Kacchan* shaped mental block.

All these years he thought he had buried his inner child that yearned for love and Kacchan—but oh, how wrong he was. Not only had the younger version of him survived in the darkness all these years, it had burrowed its way into his very core and laid crippling roots.

The haunting melody of *The Dance of The Love Birds* echoed in his ears.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku arrived back in Tokyo the day after killing Hiryu feeling panicked. The melody from his childhood wouldn't leave him, and as a result he kept envisioning sweet memories from when he was seven.

He numbly confirmed his kill on Hiryu with the photo and lied about there being anyone else on the roof. Izuku kept his eyes down when he said this, too afraid that anyone could see the agitated red blood vessels in his eyes from his breakdown.

Nine nodded in approval and Tomura patted Izuku's shoulder. In Tomura's eyes was a glimmer of deep pride that Izuku knew he didn't earn. Everyone in The Viper Seven was back to normal like they weren't six now. Himiko and Jin laughed in conversation while Ibara and Aoyama talked about casual business.

But Izuku didn't say a word.

Everyone's mouths moved, but all around him every noise sounded muffled, like the ghost of Hiryu was holding his hands over Izuku's ears.

ᔓᔓᔓ

"Good job on the assignment," Tomura complimented.

“Thank you,” Izuku replied emptily.

They walked into their suite together and Izuku felt like he was observing himself from the outside. They routinely showered and changed into their pajamas. Tomura’s hair was down, brushing his shoulders and he had on a baggy black shirt and black sweats while Izuku was dressed in normal gray sweats.

Tomura informed him that he was going to cook, and instructed Izuku to go sit in the kitchen.

When Izuku got to their kitchen on the other side of the suite, he noticed it looked different. The small dinner table was replaced with a longer, wider wooden table.

There were *seven* chairs instead of two.

Izuku found it strange for a split second, but was in no state of mind to outwardly question it. Instead, he took a seat on the right hand side of the head of the table.

As Tomura began to cook, Izuku didn’t say a word the entire time.

“Are you…okay?” Tomura probed. He peaked over his shoulder at the quiet teenager. “You seem pretty out of it.”

Izuku kept his lips tight. He was fearful that Tomura would be the one to push the truth about the blotched assignment out of him.

“I-I’m fine,” Izuku said. He kicked himself for stammering.

“It’s okay if you aren’t. I suspected you might be upset by what you had to do.”

Izuku was caught off guard. *This was new.*

“You did?” Izuku asked carefully, not believing his own ears.

“Of course,” Tomura reassured. He shrugged and prepped two bowls of ramen. He began boiling two eggs. “You can relax, I’m not going to punish you for doing a difficult task. At the end of the day, you still did it despite it being hard for you. That’s good.”

Izuku perked up a bit because he had never seen this side of Tomura.

“I know you better than anyone, Izuku,” Tomura said confidently. “I knew this would be hard for you because Hiryu was always…*closer* to you in a way I can’t be.” Tomura made a sour face. “I was hoping Nine would choose anyone else—but it seemed like you were the one he wanted to test loyalty with. I thought your soft spot for Hiryu might get in the way of what needed to be done but—I was proven wrong.”

Izuku didn’t know how to feel.

He was being praised for doing something he hated himself for. But at the same time, he was seeing a part of Tomura that he never experienced. Tomura finished topping off their bowls of ramen and sat next to him in the chair that was at the head of the table. The warm steam from

the food made Izuku's belly rumble, and Izuku smiled at his big brother and gave a tiny 'thank you' for the food.

Right as Izuku was about to relax, Tomura pulled a small object out from under the table.

It was the old, tattered romance novel Izuku had hidden away.

Dread washed over Izuku seeing the blond haired red eyed model on the cover.

Izuku panicked, dropped his chopsticks and his heart palpitated. "Tomura, wait. I—I can explain—"

"No need. I read it already." Tomura put his hand up and Izuku's stomach churned. "I'm not going to punish you for reading a fictional romance. But you understand this type of stuff is strictly fictional, right? *Especially* with what just happened with Hiryu?"

Tomura instantly slid back to his usual demeanor.

The regular, menacing version of his older brother was put forward and the gleam in his eye was terrifying. Izuku's back straightened automatically as he floundered around his words. Izuku tried to keep his cool as his mind flashed between the novel, Kacchan, and the stranger on the roof.

Izuku fiddled with his thumbs and hung his head. "I know it's not real."

Tomura pushed the book towards him, nearly disgusted.

"Good. As long as you know it's *fantasy*, then we don't have a problem."

Izuku nodded obediently and took the book, placing it in his lap with a slight tremble. He felt deeply ashamed.

"I was surprised to see what exactly was in that book," Tomura mumbled. He slurped on his ramen and Izuku began eating too, blushing slightly. "But I guess it makes sense you need something to fill the void for your defect of empathy. As long as you're feeding it with escapism and not in real life, I decided it'll be allowed. But, I will admit, reading that I realized something…I want to *try* to be close to you in the way Hiryu was."

Izuku nearly knocked over his bowl and whirled to stare at Tomura. "You do?"

"Yes."

"But, why?" Izuku furrowed his brow. "Why now?"

"Because I recognize you need more attention than other vipers because of your emotional defect." Tomura pointed to the book in Izuku's lap. "It's my job to take care of this team, but more importantly *you*. Maybe if I paid closer attention to Hiryu's needs, he wouldn't have attempted to run away with that civilian girl. I can't help but wonder if he felt like this unit was more closely knit, then he would have stayed with us."

Izuku deflated a bit.

This was a *preventative measure* to make sure Izuku didn't run away like Hiryu.

"I don't feel emotions the same way Hiryu did but I know you're important to me," Tomura said with a straight face. "I care about you, I do."

Izuku could tell his brother was trying his best at this awkward lecture. All of this went directly against his cruel, sadistic nature. But he was trying for Izuku's sake—like always. It was then Izuku really saw his brother for the first time.

His silver hair was fainter now. It was nearly so white there was a blue hue peaking through. The length of his hair had grown, falling over his face messily, and the bags under his eyes were darker than Izuku remembered. There were fine lines and wrinkles decorating the corners of his mouth, eyes, and forehead more than they should for someone who was only twenty two.

Under the bleak kitchen lighting, Izuku grasped how young Tomura really was.

"I'm proud of you for doing what you had to do on this assignment," Tomura muttered softly. "You really proved yourself to me tonight." Tomura sucked in a deep breath and braced himself for what he said next. "And because of that…I want to give you your own space."

Izuku's brows shot up in shock. "You mean I'm getting my own suite?"

"No. Your own *room*," Tomura corrected. "You're not ready to have your own suite yet but I talked with Nine and we're going to rearrange our suite so that the training room we have will be a second bedroom. I know you've been wanting your own space for a while and I figured this is a good middle ground."

"Thank you," Izuku said, bowing his head slightly.

"Thank you—*what*?"

"Thank you, *Big Brother*," Izuku said quietly. "This means a lot."

"You're welcome." Tomura rested his hand on Izuku's. "Things are going to be a lot different from here on out. I will make sure of it."

Right then, a loud knock rained on their door.

Izuku stood up first and walked over to answer it. When the large, metallic door opened Izuku was a bit surprised to see the rest of their unit standing in their lounge clothes with food ingredients in their hands.

Himiko peeked her head from behind Jin and with a sarcastic grin said, "surprise, baby brother!"

Tomura wiped the corners of his mouth with a napkin before gesturing everyone in.

Ibara and Aoyama greeted Izuku with warm smiles. Jin's shoulder bumped Izuku on the way in and Himiko continued to grin darkly at Izuku's shock. Izuku furrowed his brow at the sudden intrusion but then one by one each of his siblings took a seat at the table, laying down food. Ibara and Aoyama immediately went to the kitchen and began cooking.

"Ah, I forgot to tell you, Izuku," Tomura said. "I invited everyone over for dinner to celebrate your mission's success. I hope that's okay."

"That's fine with me," Izuku replied. "A bit random but I don't mind the extra company. Make yourselves welcome."

Jin rolled his eyes and flicked his wrist. "Like we would need your permission, runt."

"Jin. Play nice." Tomura shot him a killer glare and Jin shut up immediately.

Soon everyone was sitting at the long table eating and discussing their days. Izuku peered around, taken back at how *normal* it felt. This was just like in his romance novel. The family in the beginning always ate together and it was how they came to be close and loving.

Izuku chewed slowly on his heaps of food. He studied everyone talking and laughing around the table. Jin teasingly grabbed Himiko's nose with chopsticks and Aoyama was humming in delight as he downed the broth out of his bowl. Ibara looked over her shoulder at him with a tiny wave.

Tomura, seated at the head of the table, rested his elbows on the surface and intertwined his fingers. He cleared his throat and all five pairs of eyes turned to him.

Tomura slowly stood up and then smiled the best he could.

"I wanted to do this because tonight marks a change for all of us," Tomura said proudly. The bass in his voice was deeper than usual and the look in his eye was more focused. "From now on, we'll be having family dinners together on the nights we're not requested with Nine. I want us to be strong not only as a unit but as destined siblings who were lucky to find each other."

Family.

Izuku's heart thumped so loud he thought Tomura heard it.

Everyone at the table shrugged nonchalantly and gave approving sounds. They bled into chit chat around the table about what foods they should cook, how to cook it, and who would cook what. Soon they were all discussing mundane things like sports, topics they never would go over in any other situation.

It felt so normal.

Part of Izuku liked the idea of them being more than a unit of venomous assassins. But the other half of him took a millisecond to assess Tomura's motives. He noticed Tomura's cutlery was gold, much like Nine's.

Then Izuku glanced at the extra chair at the end of the table that didn't have a body in it.

It was lonely and heavy with absence.

Izuku could see the faint visual of Hiryu's ghost with a bullet hole between his eyes. He was sitting there staring at them as blood oozed from the wound in his face. It was no longer just his irises that were black, but now the whole of his eyes were swallowed up by the color obsidian and it mimicked two voids sitting in his skull.

Hiryu's ghost wasn't smiling. His face was pulled down into an eternal frown with envy for the living in his eyes.

Hiryu's phantom whispered, *"be careful Izuku, or you'll be next,"* in a lilting voice.

Izuku's body chilled down to his bones.

He hoped the blond stranger bled to death on the roof where he left him. He needed his secret mental block to die with that man because Izuku was more defective than he thought—more than Tomura knew—and far more than The Viper Academy would ever allow within their walls.

Izuku was as good as dead if anyone ever found out because now, Izuku was unsure if he could do the one thing he was trained to do.

He didn't know if he could go for the kill when faced with blond hair and red eyes.

Chapter End Notes

I hope you enjoyed!! Please let me know your thoughts, theories and screams in the comments below! I love reading them ^^

Chapter 20: Entr'acte IV

Chapter Summary

A series of encounters between two fated souls.

Chapter Notes

Helloooo and welcome back!!! :3

Firstly, thank you to the love of my life Luna for betaing like always!! She's amazing 💜💜💜

So, originally, this chapter was going to be 40k because the actual "Incident" ended up being such a dozy it was 15k alone. All the different Viper relationship that have been building come to a head into a huge clusterfuck basically. But after Luna read through it, we found a good place to cut it and now that gives you guys two more chapters!!

Without further rambling, please do enjoy all bakudeku moments here <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 20 — **Entr'acte IV**

.

.

.

2 years until The Incident

True to his word, over the next year Tomura hosted dinners every night—and every night that single, lonely chair remained.

Sometimes, Izuku swore that he saw Hiryu's phantom occupy the creaky chair. He could hear the sound of it go back and forth with weight when he was in his bed. Part of him knew it was the guilt distorting his senses. But the other half of him was convinced he was rightfully being haunted by the ghost of his sins.

He killed someone he loved, and that blood would never come off his hands.

Ever since Vienna, Hiryu's voice echoed in the back of his head like a second consciousness. Each thought was a taboo opinion that would never leave Izuku's mouth.

"Awfully kind of that sadistic bastard to start treating you like family after I was out of the picture," Hiryu's ghost muttered in Izuku's ear any time Tomura offered Izuku an ounce of kindness. *"He only plays nice with people he can control."*

The worst part was that Izuku didn't disagree with these thoughts. He was often bombarded with these opinions during their family dinners.

Their dinners weren't always all six of them, due to varying degrees of assignments. Sometimes it was four of them. Or five. Sometimes it was solely Izuku and Tomura.

For meals, Izuku and Aoyama often handled preparing the desserts. Tomura and Ibara always cooked the main course. Jin was always on drink duty and Himiko was on appetizers. Izuku was surprised to learn Tomura and him had similar tastes in foods, and his big brother would always reward him after assignments with a main dish Izuku could hand pick.

Izuku grew to love these moments because during this small segment of the day he felt like a normal person.

He didn't feel like a slithering viper, he felt like a regular teenager having meals with his sisters and brothers.

Notably, everyone else seemed different too.

Tomura seemed more relaxed and sometimes, if Izuku squinted, he could see the semblance of something close to a smile tugging at his big brother's lips.

Within the year, Tomura had even gotten several new piercings that complimented his cluster of ink black tattoos. He pierced his ear four times on each side and got snake bites to match his ever growing viper tattoo collection that slithered up his arms.

Aoyama became a bit less shy. He and Izuku grew closer and would often find themselves seeking out movies together in their free time. They shared a checklist of all the films they wanted to see and found mutual ground in horror films.

Ibara soon let out her love for aesthetics and fashion. She deeply enjoyed dressing up and playing the part of whatever role she was in. It came as no surprise to them when she began leading the department of espionage.

Soon Jin eventually warmed up to everyone. He let them in on his love to travel and started proposing trips they could all take together. They all liked the idea, and over the past year they would find themselves on vacations in different places around the globe. Nigeria. Thailand. France. Chile. They even went to Antarctica for a weekend all together.

All of his siblings suddenly felt like people instead of vipers.

Even Himiko was humanized a bit to Izuku—but only a bit.

She was the only one to never warm up even slightly to Izuku.

One evening when the two of them were coming back from a stake out in Matsue, she made it viciously clear that Izuku was her anathema.

It had been a beautiful night in that city when the encounter occurred. The sky was full of sunset-colored clouds and fallen Sakura blossoms poured down like rain.

Izuku miscalculated their closeness and smiled at her.

Her reaction was visceral—she pushed Izuku up against a cold brick wall and immediately Izuku went on the defense and grabbed her right back. Their glares clashed like fire and water, and all the tension in the air was as visible as steam rolling off from them.

“Let’s be clear, I will *never* consider you family,” Himiko spat. Her lips had twisted into a nasty snarl and the venom in her words felt like acid. “Do you really think I would forgive you for what you had done to Sen so easily, *hah*? You killed him and now you’re wrongfully in his spot.”

“Get over Sen already, Himiko,” Izuku snapped back. “It’s almost been eight years!” He pushed her off, regretting the simple gesture of a smile. “Even Jin has almost let go of it and Sen was his *Little*. Why can’t you accept that maybe I deserve to be here as much as you do?”

“Because I see *through* you, Izuku.”

A dark shadow danced across Himiko’s face and her eyes sharpened like blades. Pinned underneath Himiko’s noxious glare, Izuku straightened his back with a scowl.

“You’re still the same, sniveling cry baby from when we were kids,” Himiko accused. “Just because you’re better at hiding how defected you are, doesn’t mean you’re *not*. Sen was perfectly cruel. He was a *real* viper. *You*—you’re nothing but a *lamb* cowering behind Tomura.”

Izuku now understood there wasn’t a shred of camaraderie between them.

“I’m as much of a viper as you are, Himiko,” Izuku defended.

“No. You’re *not*. Vipers don’t have weaknesses and I *know* you do. Tomura has been good at hiding it from Nine, but I know why your punishments are private. He’s protecting you from being discovered as defective.”

Izuku stilled at how spot on she was and Himiko continued speaking.

“I’m going to find out exactly what that weakness is, Izuku,” Himiko promised. Her voice was as solid as the ground she wished to bury Izuku in. “And when the day comes, I’m going to use your weakness against you to lead you straight to slaughter like the lamb you are.”

If this had been before Vienna, Izuku would have rolled his eyes and marched forward. He wouldn’t have thought of it twice and gone on to practice an extra round of sparring with

Tomura to make himself feel confident in his rightful spot in this family.

However, Vienna happened and Izuku was now *painfully* aware of his weak spot:

Blond hair and red eyes.

Izuku stiffened ever so slightly.

The ghost of Hiryu leaned in to whisper, *"I told you you'd be next if you weren't careful."*

Izuku chilled and goosebumps ran along his forearms. He backed away from her with a careful assessment and strode away from the conversation.

They didn't speak all the way back to Tokyo and Izuku no longer tried to bond with her. In fact, he did the opposite. When they came back from Matsue, Izuku made sure to put extra distance between him and Himiko.

Because she was right—he did have something to hide.

ᔓᔓᔓ

It was now a quiet evening in their home in Tokyo. The summer was here and Izuku's eighteenth birthday came and went with the breeze.

Currently Ibara, Jin, Tomura and him were stationed in Nine's debriefing office.

They were waiting for their handler to come in. He was running slightly late which no one seemed to mind. Jin and Ibara were currently gossiping about people in the underground. Tomura was off to the side with Izuku, casually leaned against the window dressed in all black.

Izuku stared up at his big brother. Something in Tomura was tenser than usual and Izuku could feel it like a coil ready to snap.

The two large double doors opened, and in strode Nine. His silver hair was down today, and his power suit was a deep purple. Tucked safely in his arms were four separate red folders.

The four assassins lined up on cue.

"110, you'll be on a solo assignment in Beijing," Nine said. "Make sure to read through the details carefully because it'll be a complicated one. 199—you'll be in Toronto this next week. 117 you'll be here. I have some clients from the yakuza that want to meet with you."

Nine handed each of his siblings the folders, and Izuku patiently waited for his own.

However, Nine looked him up and down slowly before tilting his head. His well manicured fingers traced the twin viper emblem on the folder thoughtfully.

"217," Nine called Izuku's number. "This next assignment is going to be a new type for you. Upon discussions with Tomura, you'll begin taking up a more specific type of assignments

into your portfolio given your new developments."

"Which developments would that be, sir?" Izuku asked, mildly confused.

"Your looks," Nine said bluntly. "Being attractive is a deadly asset of its own. Some missions require getting close to a person through their weakness—and for many in our world their weaknesses are beautiful faces and sex. You will have Jin and Ibara to help guide you through that as they are also vipers we send on these types of assignments."

"Understood, sir," Izuku said automatically.

He in fact did not understand.

Nine handed him the folder and Izuku felt extremely caught off guard.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku was now sitting at their end of the day family dinner.

Everyone was home on a rest day and the main meal was chicken katsu. Izuku was brooding at the table, thumbing through his red folder with freshly damp hair from his shower.

This was the first folder since Hiryu's that Izuku broke his vow of not reading the whole details. It wasn't because he wanted to know more about the mark—but he wanted to know exactly what the hell he was being asked to do.

His mark was a young drug smuggler by the name of Chih-wei Tang. The target possessed unfairly kind eyes and perfect teeth. But according to the file he had one giant weakness: barely legal men. He especially liked lean, young men with blue hair and Izuku fit the profile of being *exactly* his type.

All he needed was a wig and he'd have Chih-wei hooked.

It was a seduction operation that required sneaking into a large party Chih-wei was hosting. Izuku was to flaunt his assets enough to catch Chih-wei's attention. Then if all went as planned, he would be dragged off to somewhere private and allow the man to ravish him.

And when Chih-wei's guard was down, Izuku was instructed to kill him.

Izuku blanched at the fine print.

"This says that I have to wear a *playboy* bunny outfit?" Izuku was exasperated. He huffed and put down the stack of papers like it was making him ill. "I don't get it. Why am I doing something like this? I'm a poison sniper, not a seduction agent."

"Because you're *very* pretty," Aoyama said with a laugh as light as a feather. He pointed up and down Izuku's body with his fork. "In case you haven't looked in the mirror recently, you are shaping up to be quite the looker. You got the whole doe eyed minx thing going for you with those freckles."

Freckles.

Izuku wanted to sarcastically scoff.

After the painful encounter with Inko, Izuku preferred to forget what he looked like. He couldn't find any vanity to regard his freckles as a thing of beauty when they were the reason his birth mother couldn't look at him.

"You're also exactly the type a lot of criminals love to take to bed," Ibara informed with a pity filled half smile. She gave him an extra dumpling on his plate and patted his back. "You'd be perfect for these types of missions because no one will ever expect a sweet looking guy to harm them."

It was strange hearing himself described like this.

All Izuku knew was he filled out more and grew slightly in height. But compared to Tomura, Izuku always felt small. Tomura shot up to be nearly 190cm in the past year and filled out to be one of the more muscularly built of their unit. Izuku remained lean and stopped right around 167cm.

"And I have to do these assignments?" Izuku asked cautiously. "Can't I decline?"

"Unfortunately no," Ibara said. "Whatever Nine asks of you, you have to do. He already instructed me and Jin to train you for this. We'll be working closer together so I can begin to teach you seduce and kill techniques."

Izuku groaned. He hung his head in his hands to hide his blush.

Everyone at the table besides Tomura laughed.

"This is the price of being an attractive assassin, baby bro!" Jin grinned wide as he took a giant bite of his chicken. "Nine uses me and Ibara all the time for these types of missions, don't worry. It's not as bad as it seems. You only *sometimes* find yourself having sex."

At that, Izuku shook his head and squirmed in his seat.

"I don't know if I feel comfortable with this," Izuku said wearily. "This seems a bit…*much*."

"Oh, please." Himiko groaned from across the table. "Don't tell me you're a prude."

"I'm not a prude," Izuku rebutted. "I just never considered having sex on an assignment. Weren't we taught to not do that because it creates unneeded loose ends?"

"Yeah, but there's always leeway," Jin said flippantly. "We're The Viper Seven. We can do whatever the hell we want to as long as a body is in the ground."

Aoyama studied Izuku and asked, "Not even once were you curious about getting into bed with any of our clientele?"

“No, he hasn’t been *curious*,” Tomura cut in. There was an edge in his voice as sharp as his machetes. It was only then Izuku realized Tomura had been silent this whole conversation. “Izuku has kept his mind only on work this whole time *correctly* like vipers *should* be doing.”

Tomura was sitting in a formal position, watching Izuku while strumming his fingers along the wooden table. It was plain as day that he was irritated at this topic. He glared lightly at everyone and the conversation almost died.

Almost.

“Aw, c’mon Tomura,” Jin, who was the least afraid of death, humored. “You really kept him that heavily sheltered this whole time? You’re an impressive Big Brother. Before my Big was sold to the Governor, he told me to go fuck as soon as possible. One of the many pleasures we Vipers can indulge in.”

“I bet Izuku is the only virgin at this table,” Himiko taunted.

Izuku bristled and became immediately defensive. “I am not!”

“You’re not a virgin?” Tomura whirled his glare on Izuku.

“I-I mean, I am.” Izuku fumbled his words. He was surprised by how serious Tomura’s stare became. “But surely not *everyone* has had—er, *relations*. I’m not the only virgin here… right?”

There was silence across the table.

No one spoke up and Izuku’s mouth dropped open.

Everyone? Absolutely *all* of them?

Izuku spun to Aoyama, who was bashfully rubbing the back of his neck.

“Aoyama? You too?” Izuku gasped in disbelief.

Aoyama gave a tiny shrug and a smile. “It randomly sort of happened? I was hanging out in Hadeus one day after work with some of our clients and we went to play darts. Next thing I knew we were heavy petting and heading up to a motel. It’s only natural, we’re all human.”

Izuku was shocked. He turned to his big brother next. “…Even you, Tomura?”

Tomura stayed silent at first before sighing in defeat. “Yes. But sex is just sex. It’s solely for pleasure, power or dominance.”

“Or *money*,” Jin chimed in. “I sold my virginity to the highest bidder in the Yakuza to buy my rarest sports car. Turns out, a lot of people will pay steep dollars to fuck a trained assassin. Especially a Viper—we’re a rare commodity.”

Izuku slumped in his chair when heat poked at his cheeks.

He was teased a bit longer before the topic naturally shifted into something else. Izuku stayed quiet, too lost in his thoughts to contribute to whatever his siblings were discussing.

Admittedly, Izuku hadn't thought about sex before.

He didn't know when he would ever have time to be intimate like that. Yet *somehow* everyone, including *Tomura*, found the time for pleasure in their hectic lives.

But Izuku now supposed that it made sense when he connected all the dots.

Within the last year their unit was given more freedom. Because of their rank, they were fully immersed in the lifestyle of the underground world now. They frequently hung out in Hadeus in the open with crooked politicians, gang leaders, drug smugglers, and Yakuza henchmen. The organized crime in Tokyo was a city within a city at this point.

Ibara, Aoyama and Jin were regular club goers these days. They were found hopping from bar to bar high on various contraband. Himiko now deeply enjoyed gambling games where lives would be at stake for her to take.

Even Tomura was allowing himself to bask in the darkly tinted scene that was their lifestyle. Only difference was that Tomura didn't go to clubs unless it was for discreet meetings.

He would come back with documents and folders Izuku wasn't sure Nine knew about. His older brother was often out on his free days and sometimes Izuku could overhear conversations that sounded riddled with construction terms. Blueprint. Beam. Asphalt.

Izuku thought maybe Tomura was building something, but whenever he asked, his brother deflected.

Maybe Izuku had it wrong this entire time and all that was a sex thing.

ᔓᔓᔓ

At the end of the dinner everyone left, leaving Izuku and Tomura to wash the dishes alone.

"You don't have to let them sexually touch you," Tomura advised without looking at Izuku. He rolled up his sleeves and lathered up a dirty plate. "Kill the mark before they can go that far. Jin enjoys snuff sex, that's why he always winds up further. Ibara doesn't sleep with the people she kills."

Izuku nodded, silently soaking in the information.

He continued to wash the dishes. He kept his focus on his watery reflection in the dishwater. He could vaguely see an inkling of himself and noticed how shiny and full his curls were.

Tomura then put a hand on Izuku's shoulder and gently turned him so they were facing each other.

Izuku could feel the lecture incoming and awkwardly shuffled on his feet.

“Assignment or no assignment, sex is something you shouldn’t take lightly,” Tomura started. He held an unreadable expression. “You’d ask my permission before you did anything that reckless, wouldn’t you?”

Izuku nodded automatically again. “Of course.”

“Good,” Tomura said. “Especially in the social circles we’re in. With your looks, a lot of people will want to chew you up and spit you out. Or take advantage of you. Or force themselves on you. There’s no need to invite all that outside calumny into your life all because your hormones are running high.”

“What about you? You’re not a virgin and you didn’t tell me,” Izuku grumbled.

“It’s different for me,” Tomura said sharply. He narrowed his eyes and Izuku immediately regretted his words. “Do I have to remind you that only *one* of us is defective?”

There it was: the broken piece of Izuku Tomura always held over his head.

Izuku thought about the tiny, forbidden kiss he shared in the nook now over ten years ago.

Then he immediately thought about the stranger on the roof who he failed to kill. A direct result of that year he shared with Kacchan.

“Of course,” Izuku murmured, shying away from his secret. “Sorry. You’re right and you know best.”

“Glad you see it that way,” Tomura said. He pushed a stray curl out of Izuku’s face. “You’re going through a lot of changes and your brain is going to make confusing decisions because of new hormones.”

Izuku believed it, but he couldn’t explain why he felt so embarrassed about this topic.

When Izuku didn’t answer, Tomura leaned over the sink tiredly and clasped his hands together. They held eye contact and Izuku noted the immeasurable protectiveness in Tomura’s eyes.

“I’m only like this for your benefit, okay?” Tomura muttered.

“Okay,” Izuku whispered. “I understand.”

Tomura then lifted two fingers to push Izuku’s face side to side, inspecting him.

“You have grown into quite the rare beauty, haven’t you?” Tomura muttered. He sighed as if Izuku’s changing appearance was going to be tiresome. “You’re probably the most striking assassin The Academy has ever owned.”

Izuku’s eyes averted away from Tomura, embarrassed. “I suppose.”

“Not a bad thing, but be mindful,” Tomura warned. “With lethal beauty like that always comes pain.”

Later that night while Tomura was fast asleep, Izuku decided to try to google adult videos on his laptop.

He was undoubtedly curious and there were changes happening in his body that he was admittedly ignoring. Then to top it all off, every single one of his siblings had thrust themselves into their sexualities. Izuku was once again left behind in the pack.

Izuku carefully typed in the taboo search words and waited for the page to load.

Only then did he discover that Tomura put a *parental block* on all possible porn sites.

Izuku sat there gawking at the giant red exclamation point that told him he could not proceed. Izuku typed in website after website for a crumb of something—but each time was met with a dead end.

He was so flustered he didn't know what to do.

How in the world did Tomura *always* think this far ahead? Izuku's face burned bright red and he groaned into his pillow.

Then right as he was about to give up hope, Izuku peaked up on top of his book shelf. He saw the romance novel that he only used as a kill count keeper sitting as if it had a glowing light around it.

Izuku knew *exactly* what page to turn to.

He grabbed it, and for the first time in five years, read the words on the page. Izuku sank into his bed with a candy colored blush shyly. His cheeks reddened upon reading the words, and heat crawled across his skin in a way it hadn't before. He squirmed slightly in his bed and pressed his knees together when he got to the overly detailed ravishing.

This was much more vivid than he remembered it being, but also—it was romantic.

If this was Izuku's only example of sex, he didn't understand why his siblings made it seem so opposite. The sex in this book was *soft* and it was important to the characters. They were separated for so long that their union boiled over to heated tension.

But the way his siblings discussed sex, it seemed like the act was something solely for pleasure, power, or money.

A dull pang hit Izuku's chest.

He realized he would want to have loving sex like this but probably would never.

Over the next month, Izuku was prepped for his Taiwan assignment in extreme high intensity.

This was one assignment that Nine made clear that the mark could not live under *any* circumstances. Chih-wei had been wanted in the underground scene of Tokyo for years. Now, he slipped up and was officially located. He had stolen from several drug lords that were some of The Viper Academy's more powerful connections. If they wanted to keep those relationships well watered, Chih-wei's blood needed to be in water.

It was an assignment that only could be entrusted to Nine's best assassins: one of The Viper Seven.

Izuku took it dead-serious. He brushed up on his mandarin, and worked out rigorously with squats and core exercises to tighten up his body. Izuku noted that Tomura stopped hitting him in the face as well during this period.

It seemed like the one perk of being deemed a *pretty* viper was that his face was off limits.

Jin and Ibara trained him on seduction tactics and it made Izuku burn with his natural shyness. He had to practice a gentler voice and carry all his words like air was gliding beneath them.

Ibara put him through the ringer on how to wear heels and Jin taught him how to show off his lean muscles in a way that was subtle enough to catch people's attention.

By the time Izuku was shipped off to Taiwan, he was certain that he would have a bullet in Chih-wei's skull within twenty four hours.

While in the motel, he unpacked his luggage. Sitting inside of his suitcase were all the clothes for the assignment. On top of that pile: frilly, pink lace panties. The red folder informed Izuku that Chih-wei possessed a dire weak spot for men in lace so this part was important.

Izuku put on the tiny cloth and assessed himself in the mirror. He tilted his head curiously.

He looked soft—and *gentle*.

Blush gathered across Izuku's face when he realized he *liked* how he looked. Probably for the first time in his life. His body of freckles didn't feel like a curse, and his reflection didn't disgust him. Slowly, Izuku dragged a finger tip along the hem of the lace.

He considered switching out his boxers for these to enjoy the sensation of feeling beautiful more often.

Izuku nodded, feeling resolved about the topic. He then put on the playboy bunny uniform, fishnets and blue wig without protest.

Izuku turned on his killer politeness.

ɯɯɯ

It was easy to get into Chih-wei's party because like the red folder described—the man held devious eyes for people of Izuku's build and age. The morning before the party, Chih-wei was hand picking the server staff to make sure a 'certain standard' was upheld.

Izuku researched where the auditions were being thrown and weaseled his way into the line up. He kept a flirty gaze like Ibara taught him and allowed himself to be objectified like Jin instructed. He clearly stood out against the other assortment of men and women with his lethal looks.

As if Chih-wei was one of the most predictable people on this planet, he stopped right in front of Izuku. He grinned from ear to ear.

"*You*," Chih-wei proclaimed with a low whistle while pointing to Izuku. He tipped his golden sunglasses down on the bridge of his nose to get a better look. "You, sweetheart, are *definitely* hired. Turn around and give me a three-sixty of that perfect body."

Izuku did as he was told, and Chih-wei howled happily.

Izuku coyly smiled and tilted his head to hide his disgust. "Does this mean I'll have some special one-on-one attention as well?"

"Of course, baby." Chih-wei rubbed his palms together and leaned in to whisper against the shell of Izuku's ear, "Come by the VIP section after midnight and I'll make sure you get the full experience. The stars say it's supposed to be a meeting of fate and I think you're mine."

Chih-wei's hand became a little too friendly with the curve of Izuku's backside, brushing beneath Izuku's cheek. Izuku blushed to hide how much he wanted to drive a knife through this pervert's eye.

When Chih-wei handed over the address to his mansion, Izuku happily took it.

ᔓᔓᔓ

While on the way to Chih-wei's mansion, Izuku noted how beautiful Taiwan was. The air was sweet and the people were friendly. The green trees were tall and clustered in a protective way to shelter its population.

In contrast to the peaceful haven the country was, Chih-wei's mansion was the exact opposite. It was large, out of place and a blinding white color. Inside the building were hoards of people gathered around drugs, alcohol, and loud blaring music. Confetti rained from the ceiling with glitter catching the colorful disco lights.

Izuku arrived with the rest of the staff in his uniform and Chih-wei winked at him upon arrival.

When he was given a silver tray to serve drinks, Izuku smiled at how easy this assignment was going to be.

The night went on and Izuku distributed drinks and food with a sweet persona. Several hours wore down without Chih-wei approaching him, but Izuku wasn't worried. All he had to do was wait out the party until midnight and he was sure Chih-wei would take him up to the private bedroom quarters. Izuku would slit his throat, be out the window, and off this island before the sun would rise on Chih-wei's corpse.

As time pressed on, Izuku did become slightly antsy.

He then decided to do a trick Jin taught him to ensure he kept Chih-wei's interest all night.

Izuku discreetly made sure his backside was in view of the VIP section. He bent over ever so slightly to show off all his assets. On cue, Izuku could feel a powerful presence eye-fucking him as he did this. He bent over further, faked picking something up, and the eyes burning into him grew more intense.

Izuku stood straight up again. Now he waited.

It didn't take long before someone tapped him on his shoulder. He assumed it was Chih-wei and his plan worked.

"Hey there," a gruff, distinct voice greeted in horribly annunciated Mandarin.

Izuku froze and all the color in his face drained.

That was definitely *not* Chih-wei.

The rasp of that voice was so unique that Izuku was sure he heard it once before in German and a second time in Japanese on a rooftop.

There was no way—

"I know this is weird, but I think you're really damn cute," the voice continued and it confirmed all of Izuku's worst fears. "I wanted to, er, see if you would like to go somewhere a little more private?"

Izuku spun around with a face paler than the moon. The blond stranger who Izuku failed to kill was standing in front of him like a ghost with a grudge.

The stranger paled the same as Izuku. Then the terribly handsome face contorted in pure anger.

"You?!" They both exclaimed in Japanese.

Pure chaos ensued.

The stranger grabbed for him, but missed and pulled his wig off. The blue hair went *flying* into the sky much to Izuku's horror. Izuku cursed under his breath as he broke free from the strong hold.

His green curls were exposed for all to see, and when Izuku cut his eyes over to the VIP section he saw Chih-wei staring wide eyed at the two of them.

Izuku had been compromised—*once again*—because of this same guy.

A deadly shadow enveloped Izuku's face as his viper instincts kicked in.

He needed to kill his mark *now*.

He struggled to fend off the blond man who was as strong as he seemed plus more. Without the element of surprise, Izuku was in a grid lock of fight. He tried everything to throw the blond off his tail but found each time he reached for one of his daggers—his wrist froze and he *slipped* in accuracy.

Damn it all, Izuku thought angrily at himself.

He was once more greeted with memories of his childhood friend upon seeing such beautiful blond hair and scarlet eyes. He could hear Kacchan's voice and feel the tiny kisses on his cheeks.

Izuku willed all those thoughts back to the darkest corners of his mind—but they fought their way out like a worm. Izuku was moving slower, and he was now struggling for his life.

Him and the stranger danced back and forth in a mix of throwing knives, punches and bullets. Izuku hated how his movements were sloppier. And each time he tried to home in on his skillset, his concentration was unwillingly broken down by his mental block.

"What are you doing here?!" Izuku demanded, absolutely distressed.

The stranger yelled loudly, tripping up Izuku and bringing him down to his level. "I should be asking you that, you worthless little—"

Izuku pulled out his fanged dagger and swiped for the stranger's throat in an attempt to prove to himself that he could do it. *He could kill this guy—*

—But he *couldn't*.

Now matter how hard Izuku tried, he always froze a millisecond too late. He was being held back by memories of his childhood like ropes wrapped around his wrists, puppeteering his choppy movements.

As he spiraled, Izuku realized that he needed to find a work around swiftly.

He grunted and pushed the larger body off of him. Izuku scrambled up right and once again found himself running away at full speed. He caught sight of Chih-wei being escorted upstairs and ran in that direction.

"Get fucking back here!" The stranger screamed as Izuku started running up a flight of stairs.

“Leave me alone!” Izuku screamed back, angrily glaring over his shoulders. “I told you to stay out of my way!”

Izuku ducked several bullets and used a woman as a human shield to fend for himself. He saw the flash of empathy in the stranger’s eyes and knew the guy would never shoot a civilian. Izuku took this moment to try to get the other off his tail. If he couldn’t shoot his gun then the next best thing would be his shoes.

Izuku chucked both heels at the stranger, happily hitting him in the head *twice*. The heel hit the blond man in the eye and Izuku used this opportunity to bum rush him. They found themselves toppling off the stairs and landing ungracefully on the cold, marble floor.

Everything after that was a blur. Izuku punched him. The stranger kicked him. Izuku bit him. The stranger slammed him against the wall. Izuku tried to slice his throat and the stranger tried to choke him to death.

Desperation rose in Izuku’s body like smoke from a burning building. It suffocated him from the inside out and clouded his judgment. All he saw was a thick fog of Kacchan.

The memories from that single year were gathering like a ball of snow growing bigger and bigger as everything slid down a hill. When it became too much to maintain, Izuku messed up. He was pinned down entirely by accident. The stranger’s hands struggled their way around his neck and *squeezed*.

Izuku whimpered in shock.

This was the first time he was bested by someone who was not Tomura.

“I’m going to kill you for what you did to Hiryu,” the stranger promised with a sneer.

At the mention of his dead brother, Izuku squeezed his eyes shut.

Hiryu’s ghost was laughing at him, *“Damn. I like this guy, he’s trying to avenge me.”*

Izuku began to claw against the stranger but the other man was bigger, and far stronger. The warm body above him pushed its way in between his legs. There was a spark of friction from their pressed pelvises Izuku never felt before.

He jolted, eyes wide as the stranger pressed down on him in a way that nearly felt good.

Startled, Izuku bucked in a poor attempt to throw the other off. But much to his dismay, all it accomplished was setting off the stranger to grind down on him. A flush of heat ran over Izuku when he realized he sort of *liked* it.

The guy was far too focused on choking him to notice his whimpering wasn’t from the lack of air. But rather he was confused by the strange, new combination of affixation and heat.

Something hard and warm began pressing into Izuku’s cock. Which only worsened his situation.

By the large size and thickness, Izuku presumed it to be a *very* big gun. How the hell did that guy fit that into his pants without discomfort?

At that, Izuku decided this mission was a wash. Anyone who walked around with a gun that size in their pants sleeve was a specific type of reckless. He needed to get out before he was killed, or worse, the police arrived.

Izuku used all his will power to reach down and grab his last knife. It was tucked securely between his leotard and fishnets. In the process, he ripped his fishnets against the sharp edge of the blade. For some reason, the sound seemed to throw the man above him off his game.

The hands clasping around his throat loosened enough for Izuku to gasp for air.

Intense red eyes burned into Izuku at the same time oxygen slammed into him. The air filled his lungs, and an inordinate amount of pleasure came with it. His senses were amplified an extraordinary amount as he shuddered and his cock pulsed with white heat.

Izuku froze as mortification sunk into his skin. He nearly orgasmed.

The stranger above him was also staring wide eyed.

Shit. These were the hormones Tomura warned him about.

Izuku tried to use the moment to cut the stranger's throat—but his hand holding the knife didn't move.

His face twisted in a vicious snarl and he head butted the stranger instead. The stranger, caught off guard, cried out and cradled his skull. Izuku stumbled upright, and defensively kicked the man in the temple to disorient him long enough to get away.

Izuku ran faster than he ever did in his life.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku was inside his small, remote hotel room that night horrified. He was beat up pretty badly, and was bitterly bandaging his cuts and scrapes. The dingy gray wallpaper inside of the hotel matched how he felt. Izuku laid wide awake, recounting every terrible detail that occurred.

He was stressed out for exactly four reasons.

The first reason: a very real loose end was simply walking and talking perfectly *fine*.

But worse, from what he discovered tonight, the man was likely a trained professional bodyguard based on how calculated his attacks were. Which meant the likelihood of them running into each other skyrocketed.

Izuku needed to take care of that—but *how*?

Which brought him to his second, horrible, reason for being stressed out.

He *couldn't* kill that blond and his defect was growing larger than he ever expected.

Izuku tried everything to cut that man's throat. But each time an invisible string tugged his heart to prevent him from sinking all the way into his deadly persona. That guy was red eyed kryptonite that sucked all of Izuku's killer instinct dry.

Now thirdly: Izuku was grimacing over the very real consequences that would be waiting for him at home. He missed a mark. Izuku *never* missed a mark. He cowered at the idea of what would be done to him.

Then lastly, Izuku realized that he had gotten turned on during a mission—by the *loose end*.

Izuku grumpily laid in bed tossing and turning, trying to rid himself of the moment but it wouldn't go away.

The feeling of hands around his throat returned. The hot breath against his ear sunk into his core. The bucking ghosted his hip bones. The squirming etched on his nerve endings. That raspy voice *grunting* echoed in his memory.

All the blood in Izuku's body went rushing south every time he closed his eyes. He told his body it was *wrong*. The guy was trying to kill him—that alone should turn any normal person off.

But, Izuku wasn't a normal person. He was a *viper*.

He laid awake obsessing over the sensation of being underneath the stranger. It didn't help that the guy reminded him a bit *too* much of Kacchan.

Izuku begrudgingly rolled onto his belly.

He only really had one option to clear his brain.

"I hate this guy," Izuku muttered, flustered.

His hand snuck into the side of the leotard and into the torn hole of the fishnets. He was ashamed of what he was about to do. But he had no choice. He needed to get rid of the imagery that was plaguing him.

Izuku whined desperately as he gripped his pulsing cock and ground onto the bed.

He curiously thought about the sensation he accidentally felt today. Izuku reached up and clasped his free hand around his own throat. He tightened his grip to mimic how he felt before.

Izuku shuttered, shocked that he liked it.

He perfectly pictured the handsome stranger above him for an entirely new purpose.



Izuku suddenly understood what Jin meant by the power of ‘post orgasm clarity’.

It was *witchcraft*.

His mind felt like it had been bleached of all thoughts concerning red eyes and blond hair. Now he could deal with the very pressing matter of missing his mark.

Izuku recounted what Nine told him about Chih-wei not being allowed to live under *any* circumstances. He grimaced. There was no way he could go back to Tokyo like this, he would be practically skinned alive by Nine.

The ghost of Hiryu appeared in his head. He was looming in the corner watching Izuku’s next move carefully.

Izuku swallowed. There was *one* person he knew would help him fix this.

Izuku opened his cell phone and shakily went to his contacts. He pressed the contact that was labeled ‘117’ with shaky fingers. It only took half a ring for his older brother to pick up.

“Izuku?” Tomura’s deep voice asked. “Why are you calling?”

Izuku licked his dry lips. He clutched the bed covers and hung his head.

“I messed up, Tomura. I missed the mark and I was compromised out in the open. He saw how I looked and so did some of his bodyguards. I don’t know if I can get close to him again without raising alarms.”

The silence that followed was potent.

Izuku could feel Tomura’s slow but steady rising anger from way across the East China Sea. Izuku shifted on the old, creaky motel bed and swallowed thickly.

“Send me the information of where you’re staking out,” Tomura eventually said. There was a tightness in his tone that Izuku knew would unravel to anger. “I’ll be on the next flight.”

Tomura hung up without a goodbye.

ɯɯɯ

Izuku braced himself for Tomura’s arrival. He went over every terrible scenario and held back from breaking down by monitoring news outlets closely.

Luckily for him, it seemed like the fiasco at Chih-wei’s mansion barely made headlines. It popped up on the ten o’ clock news as a quick five minute segment: ‘Party Gone Wrong!’ and there were no photos of him anywhere.

Izuku continued to suffer in anticipation for a full five hours until Tomura arrived in Taiwan. He knocked on his door in the dead of night and when Izuku opened it, he was surprised to see both Tomura and Aoyama standing in the doorway.

Aoyama was dressed in his usual, relaxed clothing. His purple t-shirt that read ‘tech nerd’ on it was half tucked into his jeans. On his back was a large, black backpack that had several cords messily sticking out.

Next to him was Tomura, looming like a nightmare.

His head was tilted to the side, unimpressed. The coils of snake tattoos on his neck followed the motion and the piercing on his lip curled with his visible disgust. He was dressed in all black sleuth gear, with a stone cold expression in his eyes that made Izuku shrink.

Aoyama gave Izuku a tiny wave. Tomura stalked inside without a word.

Izuku quickly moved out of his brother’s path. Tomura threw down the giant briefcase on the bed and immediately popped it open. An assortment of guns, knives, and ammo gleamed underneath the naked bulb of the hotel room.

“Sorry.” Izuku didn’t know what else to say. He pulled at his sleeves nervously. “What are we going to do?”

“*We* are not going to do anything. *I am*,” Tomura harshly corrected. He cocked his gun and slid several poison vials into his sleeve. He turned to Izuku and jutted his chin towards Aoyama. “Aoyama is going to rewrite some details in The Academy’s system. We’re going to extend your time here by a tiny fraction that won’t cause Nine to notice. Then we’re going to report it as if you killed the mark.”

Izuku balked. They were forging documentation.

That was unheard of—and directly a slight against Nine.

“Should we be doing something like that?” Izuku whispered hastily. “We could get in a lot of trouble.”

“And you could get in more trouble if you report that you missed the mark,” Tomura reminded him. He crossed his arms and glared at Izuku. “For the sake of your perfect kill streak we’re going to stage this mission as if the fluke didn’t happen. If Nine found out not only did you fumble this case but needed *backup* on your first seduce and kill operative, you’d be painfully demoted.”

“Maybe I deserve to be,” Izuku muttered.

“You do,” Tomura agreed. “But I refuse to have your tarnish attached to *me*. Anything you do is a direct reflection on me and because of that, *little brother,* I refuse to let you be dead weight. Are we clear?”

This was mutiny to a degree.

Nine entrusted Tomura with a lot *because* he was the perfect viper. Nine thought of Tomura as an extension of himself that could do no wrong and would follow every rule to the final detail. But now, Tomura was taking advantage of that fact and going behind their handler’s back.

Izuku lowered his eyes and nodded when he realized he was backed into a corner.

“Yes. We’re clear.”

Izuku could feel the ghost of Hiryu bark out a dry laugh in the corner. *“I told you. Feeding right out of the palm of his hands.”*

In death, Hiryu was proven correct about his theory about what Izuku would do if it came down to obeying Nine or Tomura.

“Good,” Tomura muttered, annoyed. He pulled out his old porcelain mask that he used to wear on his past missions and hooked it to his face. “I’m going to go out and handle this myself. You two stay here and whatever happens between the three of us *stays* between the three of us.”

Tomura grabbed his sharpest machete and left into the dead of the night. Izuku watched him go, and it was as if Tomura blended with the blackness effortlessly.

Izuku pursed his lips. He turned to see Aoyama setting up at the shabby desk in the room. The other viper slowly began to pull out three different computers and connected them all with massive cords.

“I’m so sorry for dragging you into this, Aoyama,” Izuku said with a heavy conscience. “I know this was your rest week, I didn’t think Tomura would bring you along.”

“It’s okay, Izuku. I don’t mind.” Aoyama gently smiled and walked over to meet him across the room. He rubbed Izuku’s shoulders affectionately. “If it makes you feel any better, I’m not doing this because Tomura dragged me along. I asked him what was going on and he told me. I volunteered to rearrange the system for you.”

Izuku’s eyebrows shot off his face. “Really? Why?”

“Because without you, I wouldn’t be alive.” Aoyama’s expression melted into a level of pity. “That day you helped me in The Cull really was my saving grace. I do owe you a lot. If that entails using my skills to make you seem like you’re perfect and stay on the team with me, then I’m alright with that.”

“…Thank you,” Izuku said with a sad smile.

Aoyama sadly smiled back at him.

An unspoken understanding settled between the two. Izuku eyed their closely numbered marks. It was then Izuku noticed the fresh tattoo that coiled around Aoyama’s wrist. It was a single pit viper that wrapped around several times, encasing his ‘215’ mark.

Izuku looked at his own bare skin.

He realized he was the only one left of their unit not to have a viper tattoo.

ᔓᔓᔓ

True to Tomura's word, their secret mission within the operative went as planned.

Tomura stalked and found Chih-wei that night. The inexperienced drug lord decided he didn't have his fill of partying after his own was crashed. He was seen going club to club, drinking off the rails recklessly. Eventually, Chih-wei wound up in some underground mahjong gambling scene.

According to Tomura he was surrounded by five, poorly trained bodyguards who were dismissed after the gambling was done. Tomura waited until the five bodyguards were out of sight before closing in. Chih-wei went home with someone for the night with a sloppy, drunk grin.

Tomura took that window to strike and killed both Chih-wei and the unfortunate soul he chose to bed that night.

He hid the bodies and Aoyama reported it as if Izuku was the one who committed the killing.

They took the next flight back home on the tiny, private jet. Izuku couldn't help but ponder what was to come for him. Tomura hadn't said anything, or so much as looked at him. His brother slept quietly on the short flight and Izuku attempted to do the same with little luck.

By the time they arrived back in Tokyo, it was the afternoon. No one noticed Aoyama or Tomura's absence enough to say anything. Tomura gave Izuku the cue to come in an hour later after them, and Izuku followed his lead like always.

When Izuku walked back into their suite, he could feel the sharp edge he was balancing on.

Immediately a shift in the atmosphere occurred. Izuku could feel disappointed eyes digging into him. He looked up to see Tomura waiting for him on the dark, leather couch in the living room. He was sipping on a small glass of wine with one hand and in the other tightly held a dark brown belt.

Izuku kept his eyes down because he knew what was coming.

"Don't you dare move an *inch*," Tomura commanded coldly.

Izuku nodded and tensed his muscles.

Tomura stood up, towering over him. "Shirt off."

Izuku's fingers shook as he slowly undid each button. He shrugged off his shirt and took his position on the ground, kneeling.

Tomura circled behind him, casting a shadow that made the temperature on his skin drop.

"Remember," Tomura said all too calmly. He snapped the belt in his hands, testing the tension. "This is for your own good."

Izuku wished that was the first and last time Aoyama and Tomura needed to cover for him. But to his dismay, it was not.

The blond bodyguard stuck to him like glue the same as Hiryu's ghost did. Izuku felt like he was in his own personalized version of hell every time he spotted spiky blond hair and red eyes.

He encountered that man *everywhere*.

He saw him in bars.

He saw him on trains.

He saw him in shady warehouses where drug lords dealt.

Izuku was baffled. What were the chances that the *one* person he couldn't kill would keep falling in his path? It was shaping up to feel like for every ten assignments Izuku had, one would flunk because of that man.

And each time he failed—Tomura covered it up.

Aoyama would weakly smile at him to give him reassurance. But that inkling of hope would always be violently ripped away by the punishments he endured at Tomura's hand. At first the punishments were regular. Izuku could do the belt. He was used to it and the nerve endings on his back were basically numb after eighteen years.

But with each assignment he flunked, Tomura's patience with him thinned.

"It's been *months*. How do you keep messing up?" Tomura growled at him one particular night. "Are you that goddamn *useless* that I have to do everything for you?"

This was the night that life shifted and Izuku would never forget it.

He endured another punishment by the belt—but it didn't stop where it should.

Tomura kicked him hard enough in the side for him to spit up blood. He curled into his body as his brother let out all his frustrations. Kick after kick, Tomura stomped him into the floor in a hateful fit. Each blow was jam packed with resentment and Izuku didn't know where it would stop.

Recently, Tomura was prohibited from hitting Izuku in the face. Nine told everyone in The Academy that Izuku was their new prized gem for seduction cases as his face matured. Izuku was a rare green eyed beauty that was supposed to be taken care of—and because of that his face was to be handled with care.

However, this evening Tomura seemingly struck him in the face on purpose.

He reeled back his leg and gave a swift kick directly to Izuku's eye socket. A black eye and bloody busted lip was left behind.

"Why did I have to get *stuck* taking care of the most *useless* person?"

His brother let out an exhausted sigh and calmly stalked off. The door scraped shut, leaving Izuku alone with his pain.

Every possible part of his body ached. His ribs burned. His insides felt twisted out of place. The deep taste of iron was filling his mouth. Izuku sobbed at the agony he was left with. This was more damning than Tomura ever inflicted before.

He knew this wasn't a regular punishment: it was animosity built up for over eighteen years.

Izuku knew deep down Tomura hated him. Tomura *cared* in a way a parent does but Tomura *hated* that they were fatefully tied together. Tomura never wanted to be his keeper, yet he was forced to raise a child while he was one too.

Izuku tried to pull himself up by his shaky arms.

He looked up from beneath his disheveled bangs to see the ghost of Hiryu sitting in the dark corner. His dead brother was shaking his head, sad for him.

"He's going to kill you if this continues," Hiryu's phantom whispered with a deep warning. *"He's only kind to you if you're of use to him. Otherwise, you're simply a burden he's better off without."*

Izuku believed it.

He found an ounce of strength to crawl back to his room like a man who survived the trenches of war. Blood trickled along with him and Izuku could feel his chest break underneath the frustration he held for himself.

He broke down crying that night, defeated.

Why couldn't he kill the stranger?

ɯɯɯ

The morning came and Nine was *livid*.

He inspected Izuku's battered body like he was a race horse that gained an injury before the competition.

Because of Izuku's busted face and ribs, the next seduction and kill operation was canceled. They were forced to fall through on the assignment, a first for The Academy in ten years. There were no other vipers to replace Izuku while his body healed, and because of that Nine decided to punish Tomura.

Tomura being punished was like Lucifer being cast down from the heavens.

The impact quaked their whole unit and shook The Academy. Tomura was taken to the basement without a fight by the guards. He held his head high.

ᔓᔓᔓ

The night Tomura was released from the basement, Izuku made sure to be cooking in the kitchen before he came home. He figured a warm meal would ease the tension and hopefully spare him Tomura's full fury.

He was watching the news as he chopped vegetables.

The headliner caught his attention: **The Scarlet Eyed Killer.**

News of this gruesome murder was circulating all around Japan nonstop recently. One of the most prominent crime lords, Imasuji Goto, was gutted like a pig and crucified within his own playground. It was not only shocking, but impressive. Imasuji Goto possessed A+ security and he himself was a powerhouse.

So who could best him? That *brutally* on top of it?

The answer came in a singular grainy photo. It was a mysterious man dressed entirely in black with only a sliver of his blood splattered eyes showing.

No one knew who he was, but everyone wanted to. However, there was no evidence left behind. No weapon. No DNA. No hint at who it could be. The only thing that pointed to the killer was the grainy photo of CCTV footage.

Deep, viciously scarlet eyes glowed in the dark on the screen.

Izuku slowed his chopping as he stared into them.

Izuku's mind flashed a memory of Kacchan. Then the stranger. Now the grainy photo of The Scarlet Eyed Killer stared back at him with the most bloodlust Izuku ever seen.

While Izuku was deep in a trance, the door opened with a heavy thud.

Izuku tore himself away from the powerful set of eyes on his television screen. He quickly clicked the device off and the new silence seared at Izuku's skin. He turned to greet his brother, but the words caught in his throat at what he saw.

Tomura's once perfect skin looked like it was gassed with some chemical. There were now endless cracks like a broken piece of porcelain along his jaw, brow, and cheeks. It spread from the scar over his eye, stretching over his face like a distorted hand.

It looked painful. But worse, it looked permanent.

Guilt ate away Izuku as he examined his brother's face. Here he was, regarded as the 'rare beauty' of The Academy with a face that was deemed untouchable. Yet now he was

responsible for all of Tomura's disfigurement. The scar over his brother's eye from his 13th birthday was always a glaring reflection of his defectiveness.

But now, *this*. This was something worse.

Izuku's bruises would heal. Tomura's scars would not.

Tomura walked over to Izuku and flopped down a new, red folder on their garnet countertop.

"Your next assignment," Tomura said with no inflection. "It's a silent kill mission." Before Izuku could say anything further, Tomura leaned down and hissed in his ear, "If you screw this up, I'll make sure *both* of us are permanently deformed for the rest of our lives."

ᔓᔓᔓ

His next mark was a man by the name of Soto Genkai, someone Izuku heard stories about growing up.

Back then, he went by an entirely different alias: The Midnight Butcher.

The vipers in his home would whisper about how the Midnight Butcher would come for you if you didn't pass all your exams. They would all cower in their beds at the thought like he was the boogeyman. But now that boogeyman was retired, and Izuku stood in the shadows about to exterminate him for good.

Soto Genkai messed up before he went away to start a new life. He killed the son of a powerful mobster while the boy was walking home from school one night. The victim was no older than Izuku was now, and the killing was done out of pure lust for murder. No money. No hit. He just wanted to get his ax bloody.

Now that Genkai's location had been found, that mobster wanted revenge for his only child.

Izuku crept into the small home in the dead of night. The sky was a dense cloudy gray and there was a thin layer of fog. Izuku expertly picked the lock on the window with no effort and carefully opened it. He winced as he crouched, his battered body burned still. His black eye, busted lip and limp hadn't gone away but Nine still deemed him in shape enough to execute assignments.

He climbed into the dark house through the window and landed quietly on his feet. Izuku clenched his teeth through his pain and fear. He hoped that this was an assignment that was free of blond hair and red eyes—but of course his fate was cursed with those two things.

When Izuku rounded the corner, vibrant crimson eyes were shining in the moonlit hallway.

They stood there with their guns pointed at each other in tense silence. Izuku tried to breathe in to prepare himself for their routine struggle, but winced instead because of his damaged lung.

Desperation crept into him as he fathomed returning back to Tomura with another failure.

Izuku didn't know what else to do but gaze at the stranger with a silent plea.

The stranger stared at him, taken back.

The guarded face disarmed to reveal softness. The stranger's eyebrows unfurled and the frown on his lips relaxed all the way. His eyes no longer held intent to kill but sincere concern.

A flash of sadness was triggered in those dangerous red eyes.

At the sudden shift, an invisible tug in Izuku's heart pulled him towards the stranger. Izuku felt like he wanted to run into his arms and allow himself to be cradled. He resisted the motion and stayed where he was.

What happened next changed Izuku's whole outlook on the stranger.

The man lowered his gun slowly in their wordless exchange. Izuku relaxed into pure shock. The nameless bodyguard walked over to an unmarked bedroom and unlocked the door. He turned his back to Izuku, exposing a vulnerability.

Izuku's viper knew this was his chance to kill two birds with one stone. He should kill the blond now and rid himself of all future trouble and then kill Genkai.

However, Izuku didn't harm the stranger.

Izuku put his gun away and quietly walked into Genkai's room. He did what he came to do, and it was a kill that Izuku felt was different from all the others. He inserted the poison into Genkai's system while thinking about the unnamed bodyguard. He'd shown Izuku something he hadn't experienced before: mercy.

He finished his job and walked out into the moonlit hallway.

The stranger was standing there, studying him with piercing red eyes. He was trying to decode Izuku with a stoic expression.

Izuku did the same right back, glancing at him once up and down. When his heart skipped an unexpected beat, he decided it was time to go. He turned away, waiting for a knife or bullet to the head but nothing came.

Izuku looked over his shoulder once more at the strange man.

"Thank you," Izuku whispered quietly.

After that, Izuku disappeared quickly before he could hear that voice.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku went home that morning feeling bizarre.

It was as if his consciousness was plucked clean from his skull and placed outside his body. He observed himself submit the proof of the kill. Nine nodded like he always did, and everything went smoothly.

In his suite that day, Tomura's scolding stare was still there.

His brother barely spoke or looked at him during their routine family dinner. The cold shoulder was evident and a chill fell amongst their table.

Ibara wearily glanced between them, specifically eyeing Tomura's new facial scars. Aoyama shifted awkwardly. Jin attempted to throw jokes that didn't land. Himiko was the only one who seemed to be having a good time. She chewed happily on her food watching the two of them like they were a movie. It was clear she was enjoying the prospect of him and Tomura not on good terms.

Their dinner ended with barely a word, and Tomura shut the door to his room without so much as a goodnight. Izuku knew one successful assignment wouldn't earn back Tomura's trust.

But Izuku couldn't focus on Tomura even if he wanted to.

The entire day he had been distracted. The soft gaze the stranger gave kept repeating over and over in his imagination. No one ever looked at him like that before, and it stuck with Izuku.

He now was morbidly curious about what type of person the stranger was.

For the first time, he wanted to run into the nameless man again.

ᔓᔓᔓ

He got his wish sooner than expected. No later than the following week, Izuku came across the unnamed man for an encounter that shifted his viewpoint.

Izuku was on the hunt for a new mark in an underground club in Chiba.

He dressed in a slightly oversized shirt that was able to hide a tiny gun. To make sure he didn't draw unneeded attention, Izuku concealed his black eye and other bruises on his face with make up. He placed a straight black haired wig on his head and combed it neatly.

The yellowish lights were dim and Izuku kept his eyes peeled for any sign that the mark was near. He caught sight of his target from his spot on the dance floor. The man was surrounded by a posse of about nine people.

The mark himself was a middle aged British man with wiry white hair. All around him was a thick crowd of potentially bodyguards in a close protective circle. The mark was blissfully laughing and throwing money in the air at the hired adult entertainment in his VIP section.

Once it seemed like they were all tipsy enough, the group shifted in the dim lights towards the private rooms downstairs.

Izuku followed quietly like a snake, moving fluidly in the shadows. He kept a tactful distance, entirely unnoticed. He entered the downstairs through a dark stairwell. Immediately, his ears were blasted with the sounds of moaning and laughter. Once fully swallowed by the basement, Izuku could clearly see this was a secret sex club.

In several neat rows were large private rooms. Each room was closed off by velvety curtains instead of doors. The seductive giggles and groans of pleasure spilled into the air like music.

Izuku watched from the shadows as his mark moved into the biggest room. The large posse followed suit.

Izuku waited back exactly thirty minutes as one by one different people from the posse left. He counted them and noted that only one person was left in there with the mark.

However, as Izuku watched them leave he saw something strange.

Each time a person came out there was a shocked, disgruntled expression grasping them. One woman had tears streaming down her face while another man was holding his stomach as if about to vomit. The various people stumbled off, and many were cursing under their breath.

Izuku decided to take the small window before whatever fiasco caused him to miss his mark.

He moved to kill with lethal stealth, shifting into the Viridian Viper. His gun was pointed high and his venomous green eyes were dilated wide for any quick movements. He reached a hand forward towards the navy lavender curtain and grabbed it.

He whipped it open. He was ready to fire his gun but halted instead.

The mysterious blond stranger was sitting in the middle of the room on a scarlet red couch.

The man was slouched backwards and holding a glass of whiskey in his hand. His eyes were studying the small tornado he was making in his drink as he swirled it. The wallpaper behind him was a velvet wine color and his hair was haloed like an angel by a neon sign above him that read *'Fateful Meetings'* in pink cursive lettering.

Piercing red eyes snapped up to look at Izuku.

The stranger scoffed dryly.

"Of course," The stranger muttered. He exhaled roughly and ran a hand through his hair. The neon lights followed his high cheekbones and Izuku hated himself for how handsome he thought the man looked. "Your mark is already dead."

At that, Izuku staggered. "*What*?"

The tired stranger jutted his head in the direction of a concealed room behind him. He then said, "go check for yourself."

Izuku did. He cautiously kept his gun pointed at the blond and peered behind the second curtain.

There, on the black satin king size bed, was his mark. The white haired man was lying flat on his side and naked as the day he was born. The man had lifeless pale skin and his eyes were rolled back into his skull. His hand was clutching his chest and his whole body was limp.

“A heart attack," the stranger provided. “He died while trying to have a six way orgy. The greedy bastard took too much viagra and his heart gave out. We might as well call it a truce tonight.”

Izuku whipped his head to the stranger and frowned. “Why would I ever call a truce with you?”

“Because I don’t have the energy to deal with your little ass tonight.” The blond took another swig of his drink and lazily patted the empty spot on the couch. Izuku noted his slurred words and concluded that he was tipsy. “C’mon, sit down. We need to have a talk, Deku.”

“No.” Izuku’s face screwed tightly. “And who is *Deku*?”

“You,” the stranger said. He pointed his index finger with a burning glare. “*You’re* Deku, *Deku*.”

Izuku spluttered. “That’s *offensive*—”

“—I don’t give a shit, *Deku*.” The stranger leaned back and rolled his shoulders. “You might as well relax, your job was done for you by Mother Nature. That group of people who left aren’t gonna call the cops or ambulance. They’re all far too high and no one actually gave a damn about this man.”

Izuku wearily looked at his target’s corpse. Then he looked at the blond stranger.

The sign above flickered.

Izuku then gave into temptation for the first time. Little did he know it would be the start of many, *many* paths this stranger would tempt him down.

Izuku went against all his viper instincts and put away his gun. He slowly sat next to the deadly stranger, crossing a line. Izuku knew he could never come back from this, but his curiosity spiraled out of control.

“Should I pour you a drink?” The stranger muttered casually.

Izuku shook his head. “No thank you.”

“Fair enough.”

The stranger drank a full glass of whiskey in one giant gulp. He gave a throaty groan at the burn as it went down then relaxed against the sofa once more. Izuku gazed on like a moth who finally got close to the flame that hypnotized it.

His eyes and hair look so soft close up, Izuku thought privately. He clutched his hands in his lap to hold down the feeling of want that arose.

“So, what are we going to do about the problem we currently have, Deku?” The stranger suddenly asked.

“I told you to stay out of my way,” Izuku murmured. “There wouldn’t be a problem if you listened.”

“Unfortunately, I can’t do that as you see.” The stranger gestured wide, motioning in the direction of the corpse in the next room. “We both have a job we have to do.”

“I guess.” Izuku pursed his lips. This was probably the closest he was going to come to figuring a way around his Kacchan shaped mental block. “So what are you? A bodyguard for hire?”

“No, I’m a *hitman* for hire,” The stranger strongly corrected. But he paused and tilted his hand in a ‘so-so’ motion. “…*But* I’m forced to specialize in bodyguard services because my handler is an uptight old man. He doesn’t want me to get consumed by my ‘unbridled rage’ or whatever bullshit he’s telling himself nowadays.”

“Interesting,” Izuku said slowly.

Usually unchecked rage was a plus in The Academy’s book. Whatever agency this guy worked for must’ve been vastly different—and it only fed into Izuku’s inquisitiveness.

Without being noticed, Izuku scooted slightly closer when the stranger poured himself another drink. This near Izuku could study all the various cuts and marks on the other man’s skin. He wondered what his life was like and if he was similar to Izuku.

“Well, how about you?” The stranger asked.

“I’m a career assassin,” Izuku said vaguely. He swallowed the lump in his throat that was telling him to *shut up*. “And that means, if you’re mostly a bodyguard and I am hired to kill —”

“—Then that means we’re probably going to be in each other’s way. Over and over and over again.”

They both slumped at the same time.

This meant Izuku was going to continue to screw up his assignments—and if that happened then more severe beatings from Tomura were guaranteed.

As Izuku pondered privately, a warm hand lightly brushed his bruised cheek.

Izuku snapped back so fast the room spun for him.

He whirled on the stranger, hand instantly going for his dagger that was hooked inside his belt loop. He was ready to draw it but stopped when that soft, gentle gaze was staring into him.

Izuku stilled, defanged once again by those striking red eyes.

The stranger moved again. He swiped his thumb against the layer of makeup that was covering Izuku's bruises. Pain bloomed across Izuku's face from the simple touch and he leaned back.

"Wh-What are you doing? Stop," Izuku harshly whispered.

He swatted the hand away from him and blushed at the foreign intimacy of the action. The stranger studied his thumb, rubbing it with his pointer finger carefully. Izuku could see the makeup that came off his face against the stranger's finger prints.

The man's gaze grew serious.

"Who hurt you like that?" The stranger asked.

Izuku blinked once, and then twice. Again—not what he was expecting this guy to say.

"Why do you care?" Izuku defended automatically.

"I *don't*," The stranger grumbled under his breath as if trying to convince himself. "…But who did it?"

"No one," Izuku muttered. "And I'm not hurt."

Izuku scooted away on the sofa slightly when his heart began hammering—but the stranger only scooted closer.

"Quit *lying*," the stranger spat distastefully. He angrily gestured up and down to Izuku's whole body. "I saw you last week. You were battered to hell and back, Deku. Your face was basically one large bruise."

"I'm not lying," Izuku defended. His chest tightened and his throat felt heavy with the truth. "I got those injuries on a mission and *besides* it's none of your concern."

"Oh, cut the shit. I've been fighting you toe to toe since Taiwan. It is extremely fuckin' hard to land a punch on you—especially that *many*. There's no way you got those injuries on a mission. You're far too skilled for that."

Izuku opened his mouth but he felt caught.

Making up a lie like he told Kacchan when he was little wasn't going to work anymore.

The stranger drew closer again but this time Izuku didn't move—or more so he couldn't. His eyes were locked on the other's and the gravity around them felt heavier. The universe kept Izuku seated in place as their knees slightly bumped. His heart hammered when their shoulders brushed far too close for their relationship with each other.

The stranger moved again. He lifted a hand and hovered it above Izuku's cheek.

Izuku shied his face away a little, and the stranger's gaze grew a thousand times gentler.

“Let me see you,” the stranger whispered.

A tug at his heart. A flutter in his chest.

The intensity between them sharpened and Izuku could feel unspeakable vulnerability coaxed from his core. He didn’t know what the stranger meant, but the plea mixed with that voice made Izuku forget himself.

He forgot why he was here. He forgot his training. He nearly forgot who was asking this of him.

The stranger reached up and pushed the wig on his head backwards. Izuku’s unruly curls sprung free and the disguise dropped to the ground.

Next, the stranger plucked a napkin off the table in front of the sofa. He dipped the tip of it in the glass of water. The stranger’s eyes darted all around Izuku’s face as he delicately cradled Izuku’s cheek with one hand and with the other wiped away the make up with the napkin.

Izuku winced as the pressure was applied. All the pretty makeup was wiped away, revealing the ugly truth underneath.

When the stranger finished wiping his face clean, Izuku felt raw in a way he never had before.

The stranger studied his beaten face with a solemn expression. He placed down the napkin then moved to Izuku’s shirt. Izuku’s hands automatically shot out to grab the stranger’s wrists to stop him.

But red eyes were like molten lava that burned right through Izuku’s defenses.

Izuku hesitantly let go of the stranger’s wrists against his better judgment.

Without breaking eye contact, the stranger unfastened each of his buttons. The calloused hands slid his shirt off his shoulders, leaving a trail of fire on Izuku’s skin where they touched flesh to flesh. The flimsy cloth fell off Izuku’s shoulders and pooled around his elbows.

Izuku’s breathing became uneven as he was put on full display.

The stranger tenderly touched the large bruise on Izuku’s side.

“Whoever did this to you, you should kill them,” the stranger muttered. His brows knitted together in deep contemplation. “You’re more than capable.”

Izuku’s throat tightened all the way. His emotions were coaxed forward by the stranger with little effort like always.

“…I can’t kill them,” Izuku whispered.

“But why not?”

“Because the person is my family. Our relationship is complicated.”

“I killed someone who would be considered my *family* because I found out he beat my mother.” The stranger glowered at the word ‘family’, as if it tasted bad. “If they deserve it, they deserve it—and whoever did that to you *definitely* deserves it.”

Izuku wasn’t phased at the murderous confession, he had heard and seen much worse.

“Why are you so weird tonight?” Izuku asked, deflecting. He curiously eyed the other’s borderline drunken state and how unnaturally close they were. “You should be at my throat by now, not giving me life advice.”

“Don’t feel like fighting.” The stranger shrugged, shoulders heavy. “Not too long ago I found out who my biological father is after thinking it was someone else for eighteen goddamn years. Today is the death anniversary of who I *thought* was my father. I went to his grave and…I felt like I didn’t belong there.”

Izuku was surprised at the vulnerability. His arms itched to hug the stranger, but he stopped himself.

“That’s terrible,” Izuku said sadly. “I’m so sorry.”

The stranger snorted sarcastically. “No you’re not.”

Izuku was, though. But he didn’t push back because the stranger was right to doubt him.

They weren’t friends. They were actually very far from it: likely doomed to be enemies until one of them finally killed the other. But, in this oddly peaceful moment, Izuku dared to think maybe in another lifetime they could have been the best of friends.

The stranger pursed his lips to the side and crossed his legs. He made their proximity painfully obvious when his whiskey tinted breath brushed Izuku’s lips.

“I used to know a boy whose brother would beat on him similar to how you’re injured,” the stranger confessed. “I used to tell myself I would slit his brother’s throat for hurting him so badly all the time. Maybe that’s why I get so goddamn *mad* when I hear about people beating on others.”

“…Did you ever kill his brother?”

“No. Never got the chance,” the stranger said. He grew quiet and his eyes stared past Izuku into a far off memory. “My biggest regret is leaving him with his abuser.”

Abuser.

Izuku never considered that word.

He recounted all the punches, slaps, and broken bones he obtained from Tomura. He recalled the moment Tomura nearly gouged his eye out when he was seven and he needed to wear that bandage for so long.

Would Tomura be considered an abuser?

Was that even *possible* in their world?

Izuku didn't know.

The two teens sat next to each other in silence, each in their own head.

The muffled music and dancing feet from the floor above echoed around them as they did nothing. The stranger kept his eyes on Izuku's injuries in a sad way, and Izuku kept his head down, thoughts full of what exactly his brother was to him.

"Well, I have to get going, Deku."

Izuku nodded. He moved to pull his shirt back on, but a hand shot out to stop him.

"I got it," the stranger said. He offered up a lopsided grin that terribly reminded Izuku of how Kacchan used to smile. "I'm the one who unbuttoned you, the least I can do is put you back right."

Izuku nodded and offered a small smile. "You're quite the gentleman."

"I try to be."

The drunk stranger shuffled in closely. It was clear the alcohol was driving a lot of this interaction, but Izuku took it regardless.

With clumsy hands, the stranger buttoned him, laughing as he missed buttoning some and needed to start over. He carefully smoothed out Izuku's shirt collar when he was finished as if Izuku was someone else. Then he picked up the forgotten wig and placed it sillily on Izuku's head with a pat.

The stranger stood up and Izuku noted his height change since Vienna. His shoulders were getting broader and his hair was growing slightly longer into more eye-catching spikes.

"Next time I see you there won't be a truce," The stranger slurred. He narrowed his eyes in a way that wasn't intimidating. "So, be ready or stay out of *my* way."

Izuku waved the stranger off. "I got it. See you around."

"Yeah…See you around, Deku."

An unreadable emotion poured from those captivating red eyes.

Then just like that, the stranger was gone.

Izuku stared after him, feeling a sore spot inside his chest grow three times bigger. He suddenly was hurting. His body. His head. His heart. Izuku slowly touched his cheek where the stranger cradled him and was surprised to feel wetness there.

A lone tear escaped out of his eye.

Why do I feel like I should miss him?



One Year until The Incident

The stranger lied to both himself and Izuku when he said that there wouldn't be anymore truces. There had been several over the next year, but they were silent exchanges.

It started when they resumed their normal struggle. It was their very own tango of push and pull involving guns and knives. They would always try to kill each other with no luck.

However, in between these violent moments was a soft spot.

Whenever Tomura's beatings were in full swing it seemed like the stranger could tell. There would always be a give away such as Izuku limping. Or him leaning his weight off one side. Sometimes it was Izuku slower than usual or wincing when he would try to kick at him.

Recognition would flash in the stranger's eyes and he would stop.

One particular night by the ocean stood out to Izuku.

Izuku's mark had gotten away in a dramatic frenzy via a speed boat. Izuku tried to chase after him, but instead the stranger tackled Izuku into the water in a gigantic splash. They went spiraling down, and the second they swam back to the dock, they began their usual tussle.

While dripping wet, the stranger slashed Izuku's shirt when Izuku moved a millisecond too late.

The blade cut the fabric clean open to reveal dark, bloodied bruises all along his torso.

The stranger's eyes widened and both of them grew pale.

Izuku instantly felt exposed and embarrassed. Like a secret had gotten out, or like he somehow disappointed the man in front of him. He quickly clutched his wet shirt close to hide the proof of Tomura's rage but it was too late.

The stranger lowered his knife.

"I'm done fighting you tonight," the stranger said. He flung his blade into the wooden surface between them with a dirty look. "The mark is safe."

Izuku hung his head, looking anywhere but those weakening red eyes. The water droplets from his hair dripped one by one, counting the passing seconds. He didn't move, too focused on his torn up shirt and how he would get home without drawing attention to him.

As if the stranger could read his mind, the man walked right up to Izuku.

Izuku was about to swing his knife, thinking it was another attack—but instead the stranger pulled his own shirt over his head. He wrung it with his hands, and shook it out to the best of his abilities.

Then he thrusted the shirt into Izuku's chest.

Izuku blinked, confused. His eyes ranked up and down the man's chest, noting how built he was underneath the single layer of clothing.

"Take it," the stranger grumbled. "Or don't. I don't care."

Izuku hesitantly took it.

"Thank you?"

"…Don't mention it. *Ever*."

No more words were exchanged as Izuku discarded his torn shirt in exchange for the new one. He pulled it over his head with shaky hands and the smell of cinnamon and caramel overtook him. Izuku blushed a bit, realizing this was the stranger's natural scent. It was strong and potent—exactly like he was.

Izuku glanced down at the white skull logo in front. The shirt was about five sizes too big for Izuku and would probably raise harmless questions if Tomura ever saw it.

This is really kind of him, Izuku thought.

The stranger turned his back on Izuku and Izuku gazed on after him. The sound of the ocean waves moved in tempo with his beating heart as Izuku watched him disappear into the darkness.

Izuku's stomach knotted in a way it never had before as he clutched the hem of the shirt.

ᔓᔓᔓ

He was nineteen now and all his fixations were on the blond haired stranger that reminded him of Kacchan. He felt like he was betraying his childhood pretend-husband in a way, but his fascination for the blond grew each encounter.

Sometimes Izuku found himself studying the stranger through the bullseyes of his sniper rifle if he didn't have to get close to the mark.

On those nights, Izuku realized there was a lot you could learn about a man through a sniper rifle.

He learned the stranger smoked once with a mark and decided he didn't like it. He also learned the stranger was a natural blond based on his roots. And he learned the stranger knew he was handsome by the way he cockily smirked anytime someone hit on him.

But most importantly, Izuku learned how gentle he was.

One day, through the lens of his sniper rifle, Izuku witnessed the stranger picking up a wounded love bird. The stranger held the tiny bird in his hands, and carefully tended to it until it flew away again.

The stranger smiled at the sky and Izuku's heart fluttered at the sight.



When Izuku ran into the stranger again, he let himself get purposefully caught in the middle of a fight.

It had been the two of them in a dingy warehouse. The mark successfully escaped and no other witnesses were around. Izuku called the mission a wash a long time ago, but decided he wanted to stay a bit longer with the stranger.

It was a risky move but Izuku itched to be closer to the guy.

"I've got you now," the stranger exclaimed as he roughly pushed Izuku down in a chair. "I'm going to make sure you don't fuckin' get away this time and I'm calling my supervisor so he can see I'm not making you up."

The stranger was short of breath, clearly untrained in the way Izuku was. Izuku hadn't broken a sweat yet, and pretended to struggle as he was tied up to the flimsy chair.

"Oh no," Izuku said in the most convincing voice he could, but he was enjoying this. "Don't tie me up."

The stranger restrained his wrists with the rope to the point it burned a little. Izuku tested the strength out by pulling his wrists apart and noticed it was a shoddy job. He could get out at any time he wanted, but stayed happily trapped.

The stranger stood in front of him with the meanest expression he had ever seen.

Izuku curiously gazed at him, happy to be close again.

As the stranger pulled out his phone, he was about to dial a number then paused.

The stranger glowered unhappily.

"You still haven't killed the person hurting you?" the stranger asked.

Izuku realized the stranger was glaring at his neck. A deep blush spiked from his collar bone to his face when he realized where he obtained those bruises from.

Izuku had been trying to find ways to mimic getting choked while he masturbated. He accidentally choked himself a little *too* hard and now hand prints were around his delicate neck.

"He didn't give these to me," Izuku admitted. "I got these…during sex."

Silence.

He didn't know what possessed him to say that.

The stranger gawked in appall then grew uncharacteristically quiet. His eyes raked up and down Izuku's body as if assessing something.

Izuku eyed the phone in the man's hand and realized he didn't move to dial anyone. Another bad move.

"Well, tell whoever is fucking you to choke you properly or not at all," the stranger grumbled. His cheeks tinted pink. "Those aren't the bruises of someone who is doing it right."

Izuku squirmed a bit in the chair. He studied the stranger wondering how he knew that.

"How can you tell?" Izuku asked calmly.

The stranger frowned. "Easily."

The simmer in Izuku's belly grew. He imagined the veiny hands squeezing his neck again and cleared his throat. Izuku knew he was playing with fire but took the plunge into the deep end.

"What's the difference?" Izuku whispered.

"What type of inexperienced shit bags have you been with exactly?" The stranger lectured. "The difference between how you choke a lover and someone you're trying to kill is night and day."

Izuku licked his lips hesitantly as he tested a line.

"Can you show me?" Izuku asked in his airy voice.

The stranger looked at him dumbfounded, but a blush grew on his cheeks. His lips curled into a mean snarl and he cocked his head.

"You want me to show you how to be choked out?"

Izuku knew this was absurd but he still pressed on. "For future reference of course."

"You're insane," the stranger deadpanned.

He shook his head, and ignored Izuku. He turned back to his phone and began to text someone.

But Izuku's curiosity couldn't be killed. He'd been thinking about their closeness since Taiwan and despite all his best efforts, he couldn't recreate how it felt. He blushed a bit, thinking about it. But then decided he knew how to get what he wanted.

According to Ibara, Izuku had a specific allure to him.

She told him all he needed to do was lean his head to the side and let his bangs fall in his face. He could stretch his neck to the side a bit and show off how far his freckles went to add to his target's imagination. Then to hook them, he could subtly make his eyes half lidded.

Izuku did just that. Immediately it affected the man in front of him.

The stranger grew quiet as he took in the way Izuku's restrained chest breathed in and out. Full attention was on his body so Izuku tested his chances further.

"Please?" He begged quietly.

The stranger put away his phone and stepped forward.

"I'm only doing this because I can't stand to see people not practicing rough sex safely," the stranger barked. He was glowering, as if he wasn't about to enjoy what was to come. "It's how false information spreads and people get hurt."

Izuku nodded, eyeing the knife in the other's hand. It was still drawn and contained a bit of Izuku's blood on it from earlier. The man could easily slit his neck if he wanted to.

That thought alone made Izuku slightly more excited than it should have.

"First, you place your hands like this," the stranger said slowly.

The warm hand encompassed Izuku's throat and they held eye contact for several moments. Izuku could feel his heart rate skyrocket and the stranger swallowed thickly.

Red eyes danced down to his parted lips.

"After that you add just enough pressure on the carotid arteries on either side to obstruct oxygen flow to the head," the stranger whispered and did exactly what he said.

Izuku exhaled roughly through his nose.

They didn't break the long gaze they were trapped in as the hand around Izuku's throat clasped tighter.

"This way you don't crush your partner's windpipe," the stranger muttered when Izuku whined slightly. "The effect of lightheadedness is the same without the possibility of long term damage. And it's the right amount of safe that it's easy to recover from later."

Izuku felt light as a feather.

His eyes fluttered closed as he leaned into the stronghold. Slowly, the fingers around his throat began to experimentally massage into his neck. Izuku craned himself more, as his toes curled. This was very much different than how the stranger choked him before.

It was gentler but just as effective.

His eyes relaxed open so he could examine in the stranger's appearance. He never noticed how much the stranger had changed since Vienna but the difference was stark. His eyes were sharper. His cheekbones were chiseled and his chest was broad and wide. The leather jacket he was sporting complemented the silver chain that dangled around his thick throat.

But even more so, Izuku noted all the growing muscles. He looked as strong as he was now.

Izuku squirmed slightly at the mildly impure thoughts that passed through his head. The stranger let out a dry, sharp scoff.

"You're more twisted than I thought, Deku."

Izuku was then ripped out of his daze when the alarm on his watch went off.

It was a specific sound he set for whenever Tomura texted him. The thought of his older brother was like ice water dosing out whatever heat gathered in the moment. Izuku's eyes snapped open and the stranger frowned at Izuku's smartwatch. Izuku lurched back to free his neck from the hold and gave a sheepish smile.

"Ah, that's my cue," Izuku said. He twisted his wrists and ankles around in the rope and freed himself. "Sorry about that but thank you for the lesson."

"What the hell—"

The stranger didn't have much time to react. He was staggered at how easily Izuku freed himself from the ropes.

Within a blink of an eye, Izuku knocked him back on his ass with a swift kick.

ᔓᔓᔓ

By the time Izuku realized he had a crush, it was too late to stop it.

He realized it on an assignment to the beautiful city of Yokohama.

He had never been there before, and he was fascinated at how pretty it was during this time of year. The blue sky felt richer than it did in Tokyo and the bright Ferris wheel was perfect.

He had been hunting a mark who was an avid concert goer. The red folder informed his next concert was for Utada Hikaru at the Yokohama Stadium. The place was huge and packed to the brim with pulsing lights and people. Rows and rows of concert goers were dressed in rave gear waving neon glow sticks. To blend in, Izuku dressed himself in a hat, jean shorts, and a regular shirt.

Well.

Not just any regular shirt.

He put on the black shirt the stranger gave him.

He didn't know why he chose it. Nowadays he found himself wearing it casually at home, to the movies, sometimes even in the park. It was his new favorite article of clothing. Tomura asked him why he bought it so large and Izuku lied and said he liked the baggy feeling. His brother didn't question it and Izuku never led on for it to be anything else.

Izuku happily played with the hem of his new favorite shirt as he purchased a large cherry slushy.

Aoyama was able to secure a ticket for him that was exactly three rows behind his mark. It would give Izuku enough distance not to be noticed, but allow him to follow the man directly after the concert.

He took his seat, and was happy that he could see the mark exactly where he was supposed to be.

However, despite his perfect station, his view was eventually obstructed.

Directly in front of him were two people *loudly* making out. The sounds were awful and lewd. Izuku scrunched up his face at the obscene lip smacking and frenzied groping. He craned his neck to see who possessed the galls for this during an Utada Hikaru concert.

Izuku couldn't catch a glimpse of the couple's faces as they were mushed into each other too hard. But he could discern that it was a larger blond man and a small black haired man. The black haired man was stationed comfortably in the blond's lap and his big head was blocking Izuku's view.

He tried to peer around them—but it was useless.

When the second opener started, Izuku grew progressively agitated. He groaned out loud, hoping the two people making out like starved rabbits would get the hint. Didn't they know PDA was unacceptable? *Especially* in this type of venue?

Izuku was about to reprimand them, but stopped when the black haired man finally pulled back from the kiss. The couple's blushing faces were revealed and Izuku's stomach dropped to the ground.

It wasn't any blond stranger—it was *his* blond haired stranger with his eyes half lidded and biting his lip.

His gaze was the same one that he'd given Izuku in Vienna.

"God, you're so fuckin' perfect, Mako," The stranger cooed.

Cutthroat green eyes locked onto the black haired man.

Izuku never felt jealousy before. He read about it in books but no piece of literature ever properly described the ugly churning that grew inside of him at that moment. It was dark, and more overwhelming than he ever gave it credit for in movies. Izuku clenched his fists when the two hungrily kissed again.

The second opener introduced Utada Hikaru and all around him the rows of people stood up. The audience jumped excitedly, waving glow sticks and throwing glitter. Izuku stayed seated watching the two lovers in front of him with a bitter gaze.

What happened next, Izuku would say, wasn't *entirely* him. It was another green eyed monster but it was as sinister as The Viridian Viper.

Izuku stood up slowly with his slushy. Without making it too obvious, he tipped the cup lightly. All the cold, red liquid directly poured onto the black haired man.

A scream erupted so loud everyone in their section flinched and stopped dancing.

“What the hell!” The man named Mako yelled.

He scrambled off the blond stranger’s lap and everyone whirled around to stare at Izuku. Izuku feigned innocence, gasping and covering his mouth. He muttered apologies and quickly bowed to hide the shock he held towards himself. Jealousy really *was* a powerful emotion.

When he peeked from under his hat, both Mako and the stranger were staring at him.

Instantly, the blond stranger’s face fell when he recognized Izuku. Maybe the stranger was here on an assignment like he was, Izuku realized. It made sense. They were similar, always working deadly jobs and a mark was exactly three rows ahead.

Izuku patiently waited to be ousted per their routine, but it didn’t happen.

Mako groaned and put his hands up. “I’m going to go clean up, I can’t believe this.”

Mako stalked off, dripping red slushy from his head all the way to his toes. The blond stranger stared at Izuku in silent assessment. The stranger’s eyes raked up and down and a scowl pulled at his lips at the sight of his shirt. Instead of saying something, the stranger shook his head in disapproval. The blond followed behind the unhappy black haired man without so much as a second glance at Izuku.

And it *irked* Izuku.

The stranger had never ignored him before.

Izuku glanced at his target who was waving two white glow sticks to the rhythm of the song, then he looked at the two men who were walking towards the bathroom, outside of the arena.

Izuku knew he shouldn’t have followed but he was undoubtedly curious.

He trailed quietly to find Mako storming into the bathroom and the stranger waiting outside scrolling on his phone. Izuku didn’t know what came over him. *Stop it,* he told himself. *Go back and watch the mark.* But despite himself, like always when it came to this man, he walked right over to the stranger.

Upon seeing him, crimson eyes were furious.

The stranger quickly glanced at the bathroom door and then stormed towards Izuku. Without a word he grabbed Izuku by his elbow and dragged him around the corner out of sight. He slammed Izuku into the brick wall with all his strength and pinned him against the wall with his forearm. His nostrils flared like a bull about to charge for the kill.

“Why the *fuck* are you here?” The stranger spat, and Izuku was admittedly happy to have his attention.

“Same reason you probably are,” Izuku said easily. He didn’t move to unpin himself. “Aren’t you guarding my mark?”

“For once, no. I’m not on an assignment, Deku. I’m on a *date.*”

“A date?” Izuku’s eyebrows furrowed and the bitter taste inside of him intensified.

“Yes, *Deku*. A date that you probably ruined by pouring slushy all over the guy I’m trying to ask to be my boyfriend.”

Boyfriend.

That single affectionate word made Izuku’s world stop spinning.

He could see all the hand holding, kissing, and hugs that came along with that title flash through his mind. His stranger was on a date like a normal person which meant he most definitely was *not* like Izuku. He was an inkling bit normal and allowed to feel lo—

“You did that on purpose didn’t you?” The stranger said, cutting off Izuku’s thoughts.

“No, I didn’t,” Izuku lied through his teeth. He churned unhappily as his thoughts stayed caught in the imagery of the stranger having a lover. “It was an accident.”

“There’s no such thing as accidents when it comes to you,” the stranger said in a short tone.

The stranger eyed Izuku up and down, and removed his arm.

Izuku stayed pressed against the wall with a sour expression.

They stared at each other in a quietness that felt different than all the other times. Usually they were at each other’s throats or the stranger was giving him a pity filled stare. But this time, he was looking at Izuku with disgust—like he wasn’t worth his time.

“I’m going to get back to my date,” the stranger said. “Leave me the hell alone for the rest of the concert or I’ll kill you.”

The stranger turned his back on Izuku and marched around the corner.

“Fucking freak.”

It was murmured so soft Izuku nearly missed it. But the stranger said those two words under his breath so viciously that it cut right through all of Izuku’s thick skin.

Fucking freak.

It hurt in a way that Izuku knew shouldn't.

They didn't know each other. They didn't even *like* each other. But Izuku felt ugly. He felt ashamed for what he'd done and the label 'freak' stuck to him like it was written all over his forehead. However, he couldn't help but want the stranger's attention again. No matter how angry. Or furious. Or laced with the intent to kill.

But nonetheless, Izuku was given absolutely *nothing* for the first time.

Tediously, Izuku peered around the corner to see the stranger meet up with Mako.

The stranger affectionately rubbed the flustered man's shoulders to calm him down. Once it seemed like Mako rebalanced, they began to return to their seats. A single, unhappy glance over the shoulder was all Izuku was given before the stranger wrapped his arm around Mako protectively.

Izuku stood there, greener than he ever felt.

"*It seems like all you'll ever have is that piece of cloth*," Hiryu's ghost said pointedly. "*Mako gets the rest*."

Izuku's eyes teared up as he tugged at the hem of the oversized shirt. He was jealous of Mako and envious of the stranger.

Together, they both basked in a light Izuku would never see.

His eyes welled up at the thought of Kacchan.

ᔓᔓᔓ

What happened next would be the last domino placed into a long string of events that went tumbling into oblivion. It would affect more people than Izuku would know, and it would be the beginning of his life fully unraveled down to its hinges.

Izuku cut the mission short to return to Tokyo, where things made sense.

He couldn't stay seated behind the blond stranger and his *date* after that. Like a bat to the face, Izuku painfully admitted he had a full blown crush. What was worse he had a crush on a man whose name he didn't even know and the guy *surely* hated him.

During the middle of the concert, the mark decided to go for a refill of his Pepsi.

Izuku followed the mark. He slipped the man a drop of poison that absorbed through the skin. It was the tiniest interaction to administer it, the brush of their hands in passing. The poison was slow acting, and Izuku waited outside for his confirmation versus returning back to his seat.

Right on time, within the next hour the sound of ambulances could be heard in the distance.

A body bag was carried out of Yokohama stadium and Izuku quietly disappeared into the night.

He cried all the way on the commute back to Tokyo. He didn't know what came over him but he was unable to put a stop to the tears. He softly cried with his head down the whole time, watching as wetness gathered on the oversized shirt.

The jealous monster inside of him was replaced by the lonely boy he was. He repeated what the stranger had called him.

Freak.

Izuku walked into Hadeus with his head down.

His arms were crossed defensively over his chest as he lugged his tired body along. He didn't know what to do now. But knew he needed to figure out how to kill this growing crush before it devoured him whole like Hiryu.

Izuku routinely walked past a fancy restaurant near their home. It was one of Tomura's favorite spots because it was the center of all organized crime in the city. Yakuza, mobsters, and criminals all alike gathered here for private meetings that the governor turned a blind eye to.

Which is why Izuku wasn't surprised to see Tomura across the street walking in. However, what he *was* surprised about were the two people his brother was with. Izuku's pace slowed when he recognized one man as Chisaki Kai, the Yakuza heir. He'd only seen the man from afar but he knew what he looked like with his crow-like features and reddish brown hair.

However, the man next to Chisaki was the one who made Izuku stop walking entirely.

It was their Grand Father, One.

Somehow, he was more threatening in person and his stature was muscular for a man of his age.

His curly hair was pure white now and the power he radiated was tangible. There was a dark gleam in his piercing red eyes that Izuku had never seen. To top this all off, he was sharply dressed in a clean black pinstripe suit and decorated in mountains of golden jewelry. In his right hand was a gold cane in the shape of a hissing viper with diamonds as eyes.

One touched Tomura's shoulder like he was a son to him.

Tomura held the door open for the two men and glanced over his shoulder carefully. Then he did a double take when he caught sight of Izuku standing like a statue.

Quickly, Tomura said something to One and Chisaki. He then hurried across the busy street to Izuku. Izuku peered around his brother to see the two powerful men take a table inside the restaurant as if this wasn't the first time they met all together.

“Izuku, what are you doing back in Tokyo so early?” Tomura immediately asked, skipping hello. “Your mission isn’t scheduled to finish until tomorrow night.”

“I disposed of the mark early,” Izuku muttered. His brows pinched together and looked at Tomura suspiciously. “Was that Chisaki? And *One*?”

“…Yes,” Tomura said. He folded his arms and leaned down to Izuku’s height. His gaze grew the most serious Izuku ever saw it become. “Don’t tell Nine. It’s a private meeting between the three of us.”

Izuku looked at his brother sideways, not liking those implications. “What would you have to meet privately about with One and Chisaki that Nine couldn’t know?”

“Nothing that you have to worry about. Are we clear?”

“*He’s up to no good,*” Hiryu’s ghost murmured. “*I told you*.”

Izuku’s bloodshot eyes flickered between his brother and the door across the street. As he did this, Tomura was watching him like a cobra. Surely he was looking for any indication that Izuku would tell and how to make sure he didn’t—and that threatening glare alone made Izuku take a large step back.

“We’re clear,” Izuku whispered. He curled into himself when the energy shifted darkly. “I won’t tell anyone.”

“Good.” Tomura studied him for a millisecond longer. “Now go home. If anyone asks where I’m at, say I’m running errands for an upcoming assignment.”

Izuku nodded and did as he was told.

He walked home in the howling wind. It was like the breeze was pushing him to go back and figure out what was happening. But his fear of Tomura’s rage was more compelling.

Izuku walked home, ignoring the feeling of Hiryu’s phantom eerily pointing to the restaurant.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku stayed wide awake in his bed all night. He laid on his side, gazing out the large window to their neon city. His sad reflection was ghosted back to him and in the haze, he could see a blend of him and Hiryu. The events of the evening replayed in his head as he softly cried.

Then the door opened carefully.

It was pushed open so softly Izuku almost missed it. It was as if Tomura was sneaking in after being out all evening. Which he *was*, was the killer part. It was the dead of night, and Izuku wondered what exactly Tomura needed to discuss with both Chisaki and One for so long that he missed their scheduled family dinner.

Next, the door to his bedroom opened suddenly.

Izuku quickly wiped his face, disguising his weakness. He peaked over his shoulder to see Tomura looking at him in the dark room.

“Ah. You’re awake,” Tomura said, surprised. “I was checking in on you.”

Izuku sat up on the bed. “I didn’t tell anyone about the meeting, if that’s what you’re wondering.”

Tomura nodded in approval and Izuku realized how tired his brother seemed.

Tomura dragged his feet a bit as he walked inside of Izuku’s room. His brother peered around and glimpsed at the decoration Izuku had done recently in his re-found interest for fictional romance.

Izuku had a large book shelf of newly released romance novels. It was all organized by the author and he gave his favorites golden star stickers on the spines. On his wall were vintage posters from movies such as *Casablanca*, *In The Mood For Love*, and *Drowning Love* next to his extensive dagger collection.

Tomura then glanced at Izuku.

“Were you crying?” Tomura asked.

“No,” Izuku quickly replied. He shifted uncomfortably, and wiped at his eyes to make sure no tears were showing. “My allergies are acting up, that’s all. It’s that time of the year.”

“Izuku. You’re lying again.” Tomura exhaled and his shoulders sagged. He tiredly sat down on the edge of the bed to look Izuku in the face. “I know what your eyes look like when your allergies are irritated. I’ve raised you since I was *seven*. Did you mess up on the mission again?”

“No, I promise. It’s allergies.”

“Izuku. Tell me the truth.” Tomura’s face hardened sternly and he narrowed his eyes. “We have our one rule: lie to everyone but me.”

But Izuku had been lying to Tomura ever since Vienna for a very *blond* reason.

“…I’m lonely, Tomura,” Izuku said as honestly as he could. He looked at the *In The Mood For Love* poster across the way. He studied how they gazed at each other and longed for it too. “I was crying because I’m stupid and lonely.”

“Why are you lonely?” Tomura frowned. His brother gestured to the large bookshelf and movie posters behind him. “You have me, your books, your movies and everything you could ever ask for. Not to mention everyone else like Ibara and Aoyama—”

“—No, not like that,” Izuku quickly cut off. He sighed and waved his hands. “It’s okay, forget it. Goodnight, big brother.”

Izuku turned to fall asleep but Tomura caught his shoulder and forced him to face him.

“Izuku. Explain,” Tomura said seriously. “Is this why you’ve been messing up on your missions recently?”

There was a comfort in his brother’s eyes that was rare, but when it did show up Tomura wouldn’t back down until he got some sort of answer.

“No, it’s nothing to do with my missions,” Izuku lied halfway, protecting his true weakness. “It’s my *defect*. It makes me lonely, that’s all. I saw a couple on the train and—and it made me lonely.”

Tomura sat up straight, taken back. “All this fuss because you want to have a girlfriend?”

Izuku peered at the stranger’s black shirt hanging off the side of his dirty hamper.

“A boyfriend—more specifically,” Izuku muttered with a blush.

“Ah. You’re gay.” Tomura sucked his teeth and cocked his head at a thought that passed through his mind. He nodded slowly. “That…makes sense.”

Embarrassment ate Izuku from the inside out. How did he come to a point in his life where he was admitting his potential sexuality to *Tomura* of all people?

“I-I keep trying to push down my defect,” Izuku whispered. “But it keeps coming up. I keep *wanting* in a way I know I shouldn’t and it makes me feel uneasy. I’m sorry, I know you don’t want to hear this.”

“No, I do,” Tomura countered.

Tomura lifted a hand to move a curl out of Izuku’s face.

Izuku turned at the familiar motion and was surprised to see his brother gazing at him with a contemplative look. He was expecting coldness, or a lecture but this was different—and it felt a bit too easy.

“I’m happy you could tell me this versus imploding and doing something idiotic like Hiryu,” Tomura continued. “But, how about we put this on hold in the meantime and you don’t act on anything until you get approval from me. Okay?”

Approval?

Izuku drew a blank on what Tomura exactly meant by that.

But still, Izuku apprehensively nodded and weakly said, “okay.”

Tomura gave him a tight smile. “Don’t worry. I’ll figure a solution out like always, but give it time.”

He had no choice, really.

“Of course,” Izuku said. He smiled to hide his unease.

Tomura exhaled and stood up from the bed. He cracked his knuckles, and Izuku caught the blood speckles that were littered across his brother’s forearms. Tomura walked towards Izuku’s bedroom door and gave him a single, unreadable glance.

“Goodnight, Izuku.”

Izuku clutched his comforter.

“Goodnight, Tomura.”

If Izuku was told to pinpoint the epicenter of all his mistakes, it would land here.



Year of The Incident

A year passed and Izuku forgot all about the conversation. He wrongfully assumed Tomura did too.

He continued about his life like those two particular days didn’t happen. Izuku tucked the stranger’s shirt away at the bottom of his drawer. He didn’t wear it anymore after that in hopes of starving out his crush. But, despite his best efforts, Izuku’s crush grew even without him feeding it. It grew and grew until he was having dreams about the stranger and dreams about Kacchan.

By the time he was twenty, Izuku also came to terms with his mental block.

He was doomed to always fuck up when red eyes and blond hair were involved. Instead, he found ways around it. Such as, he discovered he could shoot the stranger in the foot or in the leg. He could slice at him in an area that was non-lethal and his brain would be more kind to him.

As long as he wasn’t going for the kill then he wouldn’t be stunted.

As a result, Izuku found the *tiniest* bit of pleasure in toying with the guy. It was oddly fun to get under the hotheaded man’s skin.

“Your aim is worse than usual today,” Izuku would sometimes tease as he easily deflected any attacks. “Off your game?”

“Oh *fuck you*, Deku.”

He enjoyed the vicious rise that would come from the stranger. The blond man would grit his teeth and stare at Izuku with hate fueled eyes. They burned so deeply with passionate loathing—but still it was *passion*. Izuku found it exciting because it was the closest to passion he probably would ever come.

He kept this secret close to him. No one could ever know about this guy and the secret he carried.

Tomura and Aoyama continued to cover for him, and like clockwork Tomura dished out his punishments each time. The increased beatings were beginning to take a toll on Izuku's body. The scars, bruises, and gashes were evident all along his skin. But as long as it wasn't his face that was wrecked, Nine didn't care or step in.

Izuku didn't mind the beatings though.

As long as his secret was safe, he would rather endure that pain versus whatever would happen if someone knew about his mental block.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku happily sat at their family dinner eating Okonomiyaki.

Ibara was gone for an assignment which only left Izuku, Tomura, Jin, Aoyama and Himiko. Izuku quietly ate beside his big brother who was more apprehensive than usual this evening.

About half way through their meal, a white envelope was suddenly handed to Izuku.

Izuku stopped chewing and peaked up at Tomura who was holding it with an expectant stare. Izuku swallowed and took the envelope, slightly confused. He turned it over, searching for The Viper Academy emblem but it was blank as could be.

"What is this?" Izuku asked curiously.

"Open it," Tomura said. He rested his chin on his intertwined hands with a half smile. "It's a surprise for you that I've been working on for the last year."

Izuku peered around at his siblings.

Aoyama gave him a thumbs up, and Jin was texting on his phone lazily, not even paying attention.

However, Himiko was curiously looking at the packet as well.

Izuku fiddled a bit before carefully opening the top. He reached in and pulled out a small binder. It was white, and unlabeled. Izuku opened it and was surprised to see on the page was a profile of a man. Next to his photo were random numbers and information.

Height. Income. Age. Gang or organization affiliation. Then finally the location where he lived in Tokyo.

Underneath were descriptions of mundane things. This random man's favorite foods, places to shop and hobbies were listed so plainly like he was trying to be advertised.

Izuku quickly flipped to the next page to find the same thing. Then he flipped to the next and it was the same. Again and again and again.

Izuku stopped flipping when it became very clear: this was a binder of men.

Heat fanned across his face when he saw one very handsome blond man. It was listed that this guy worked for their corrupt governor, oversaw rigging elections, and his hobbies included sailing.

“Wh-What is *this*?” Izuku asked, voice taut and high pitched.

As Izuku read this man’s ridiculous height, a sinking suspicion crept. He connected several wild dots to hint at what was happening. But there was *no way*—

Tomura’s all too pleased expression grew. “It’s an eligible list of men I’ve vetted for you.”

Aoyama smiled.

Jin stopped texting, gawked, and exclaimed, “he’s *gay*?”

Himiko spat out her drink right onto Aoyama’s face in shock.

Aoyama wiped his face at the exact moment Izuku dropped the binder like it was made of hot coals.

“I figured that this was a nice thing to do for you per our *conversation* last year,” Tomura said slowly. He hinted just enough for Izuku to understand but for everyone else not to pick up on the fact Izuku was defected. “I put a lot of hard work into that so take your time going through it. The trouble I went through was far more work than I ever wanted to do for such an absurd thing.”

Izuku’s whole face was red as he stared in horror at the tiny binder of Tomura approved eligible *bachelors*—

“You won’t believe how many people he made me wiretap this past year,” Aoyama added with a chuckle. “We did so much digging that we found enough blackmail to last the rest of our lifetime.”

“A lot of disgusting people out there,” Tomura quipped with a sour tinge. “Everyone in that binder is approved by me. But let’s keep it a secret from Nine for now. Consider this my gift to you.”

Himiko quickly stood up and hurried to the empty seat next to Izuku. She leaned in, eyes wide with curiosity and flipped through the binder for him. She gaped like she was looking at the holy grail.

“Holy shit,” Himiko exclaimed. “Everyone in here is some sort of organized criminal connected to The Academy. I recognize all these guys from the underground gambling scene in Hadeus.”

“Yes,” Tomura said. He shrugged his shoulders like it was obvious. “It only makes sense to keep it in our circles. People on the outside would regard us as monsters if they knew what we truly are.”

“Actually, these aren’t common criminals, these are leaders or people in power positions,” Himiko pointed out. She pieced something odd together. “…What would Izuku want with these guys?”

“Izuku asked me to find him someone he could potentially have sex with,” Tomura explained.

Izuku halted because that’s not at *all* what he said.

But maybe Tomura was covering for him—right? He was trying to make it seem like a sex thing and not a romance thing in front of everyone? However, despite that making sense, a looming fog hovered above Izuku’s skin making goosebumps pop up one by one.

“*Tomura doesn’t mince his words*,” Hiryu’s ghost reminded him. “*He also doesn’t do anything unless he is getting something out of it.*”

“Damn, you really went out of your way to help this poor kid get laid,” Jin said with a laugh.

Izuku nervously fiddled with the corner of a page. He eyed Tomura who was waiting for him to continue searching through the binder. It didn’t help his nerves that all his other siblings were staring on like this was the six o’ clock news.

He was stuck though, caught on a notion he couldn’t shake since he was seven.

The sterile whiteness of the binder reflected exactly how this all seemed: bleak. There was no passion connected to the act of simply picking someone who *Tomura* deemed was okay enough. Izuku furrowed his brow when he finally realized why he avoided getting close to anyone this whole time.

He was too attached at his core to the concept of romance and this—this was not it.

“I kind of imagined finding someone on my own,” Izuku muttered in a small voice. He pushed his hands in his lap when he thought of Kacchan. “Kind of how you guys do. Y’know, organically.”

“You’re incapable of that,” Tomura said tightly. He frowned and shifted to fold his arms across his chest. “I already spoke to each of these men and they would be interested in getting to know you.”

This time it was Izuku’s turn to frown. “In what way?”

“Don’t ruin this by thinking too hard,” Tomura warned and slid right past giving Izuku an answer.

Himiko curiously peaked over Izuku’s shoulder again.

She then made a strange sound and tilted her head while saying, “Hey, Tomura. Isn’t this the gang leader you met with about learning more about the Tokyo Underground Council—”

“—Go through the damn binder, Izuku,” Tomura snapped.

Everyone fell silent.

Deep down, Izuku hated how Tomura could do that.

The fear that was installed in them by Tomura activated at the *slightest* mood shift. Jin went back to texting. Aoyama turned his head away. Izuku snapped into obedience like a magnet. Himiko also quickly sat down in her original seat and resumed her meal.

They all waded there quietly until Izuku started from the beginning of the binder.

Izuku took his time flipping through it. Not because he was genuinely curious, but because he could feel Tomura watching him with a pissed off glare. Izuku tried to actually see if there were people in here that he may like—but not a soul appealed to him.

Izuku was bluntly hit with the fact his taste in men hinged *very heavily* on his Kacchan-mental block.

Which is unfortunately why Izuku paused a little longer on the blond men in this binder.

He read the blond men's profiles more carefully. The slim flicker of hope residing inside of him wondered if any of these men were Kacchan as he scanned their ages. But as he searched, nothing came close to matching. A lot of these men were older, Izuku realized. Most were nearly twice his age.

Then the world came to a halt as his *one* weakness was exposed:

"You only like blonds," Tomura said offhandedly, like it wasn't a big deal.

But it was.

On cue, Izuku became guarded. He quickly flipped away from the blond man he was staring at in an attempt to cover his slip up.

"No, I don't," Izuku deflected a little too hard. "I like everyone equally."

Jin and Aoyama started laughing—

—but Himiko was watching Izuku carefully.

Her golden eyes homed in on him. Then she grew uncharacteristically quiet to study his body language with lethal assessment.

"No. You're only interested in the blonds," Tomura said like it was easy. Tomura leaned over and turned the page back to the blond man who caught Izuku's eye. He pointed to the man's photo and tapped his strawberry blond hair. "I can see you stare longer at blonds versus everyone else. Nothing wrong with having a preference if that's what you like."

"You have good taste baby bro," Jin said with a conceited grin. He ran a hand through his own blond hair and shook it like he was a movie star. "Blonds *do* have more fun!"

Izuku waited a beat too late for his laugh to pass as natural. He forced himself to chuckle but Himiko caught it.

She tilted her head at the way Izuku's body language shifted to defensive.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku thought his slip up was buried and forgotten, but he was sorely mistaken.

It reared its ugly head the next month while him and Himiko were on a hunt and kill operative.

Their mark was a simple man. He had brown hair and wore thick, black rimmed glasses. He was a regular business worker who skipped town years ago to avoid paying back his gambling debts to Chisaki Kai. Usually, Chisaki would say it was petty change and go about his life.

However, the death of Imasuji Goto set off a chain reaction.

Every criminal leader decided it was time to wrap up all loose ends. Even the small ones.

It was supposed to be an easy mission. They successfully cornered the mark in a barren alley with no witnesses when he stepped off the train in Osaka. But of course—fate had other plans. The mark hired bodyguards to wait for him at the train station—and not *any* bodyguards. Oh no. It was Izuku's pain-in-the-ass stranger plus two others.

The mission quickly went sideways.

Izuku froze on the spot when he saw familiar red eyes and blond hair.

Guns were shot. Knives were thrown. Himiko managed to kill the two other bodyguards and Izuku was able to shallowly cut the mark on the leg with his poisonous dagger. It wouldn't be too long before the target died after that—but when it came time to finish off the last loose end—Izuku's mental block kicked in full force.

The blond stranger was running away full speed to a train that was departing.

Himiko tried to fire off her gun and it was jammed. She snatched her mask off, began pointing and yelled for Izuku to hurry up and take the shot before the loose end got away.

Izuku switched to his long distance pistol and pulled the trigger.

The bullet barely grazed the stranger, dinging the metal train instead. The stranger was able to barrel roll into the closing doors before they slapped shut. Izuku cursed and aimed his gun again, lining it up perfectly with the glass window where the stranger's head was.

Himiko was screaming in his ear to take the shot, but as Izuku looked through the bullseye of the gun—terrified red eyes stared back at him.

All Izuku could see was Kacchan, alone and abandoned in the depths of winter.

He couldn't pull the trigger.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku sat with his head down and hands pressed on his lap. He shifted on the uncomfortable chair in the conference room as its cold surface dug into his back. The ticking clock above him felt like a countdown to his imminent doom.

They were back in Tokyo at the debrief and by some stroke of luck, Nine was out of town for the next week visiting Peter Moore. In his place, Tomura was put temporarily in charge of all Viper Seven debriefs. Himiko was standing next to him, her gaze and shadow were colder than a brutal storm.

Tomura sat across from Izuku, paperwork stacked in front of him with a red pen. His brother refused to look at him.

Between these two, Izuku's skin was boiling under pressure. He had *momentously* screwed up. He never considered that he'd ever see the stranger while on a duo mission—but he did and with *Himiko* of all people.

"Izuku could have killed him and he *missed*!" Himiko hissed. "There was another perfect shot to take too and he didn't pull the trigger. It was weird, like they *knew* each other. This needs to be reported to Nine *immediately*."

Tomura tapped his pen on the table to hold his patience. He took a deep breath in and then cut his eyes to Himiko.

"Is the mark dead?" Tomura asked evenly.

Himiko frowned. "Yes, but—"

"—But *what*?" Tomura cut her off. He narrowed his eyes. "The mark was exterminated so there's no need to say otherwise. I'm going to report on records that the operation went fine. One loose end in the grand scheme of things isn't the end of the world."

Oh how wrong Tomura was, Izuku thought. Especially about this specific loose end.

Himiko was scandalized. She dropped her mouth and stared at Tomura in disbelief. She glanced between Tomura and Izuku and shook her head.

"Are you asking me to lie to Nine for *Izuku* of all people?" Himiko spat.

"No." Tomura held their eye contact and leaned forward. He clasped his hands together and tilted his head. "I'm asking you to lie to Nine for *me*."

"But Nine is our *handler*—"

"—And he respects me the most," Tomura reminded her. "I would like to keep that respect too. So no, we're not about to expose Izuku's fuck ups as a weak spot under my watch. Plus,

even if you go to Nine, who do you think he will believe? You or me? I can always remind him of the little *sentimental* grudge you are holding against Izuku over a weak boy who died years ago."

At that, Himiko seemed to back down.

She twisted her mouth and took a stance of obedience similar to Izuku's. She turned her head away in an attempt to mask her dissatisfaction.

Izuku felt guilty and lowered his head further.

Tomura really was the only reason he was safely alive, wasn't he?

"We'll keep a close eye out for the loose end if he ever comes back again," Tomura said tiredly. He clicked his pen and began writing on his private notepad. "Tell me, what did the loose end look like?"

"It was a male, about in his late teens or early twenties," Himiko muttered. Her lips were pressed in an agitated thin line as she spoke. "He was tall, about 183cm. I didn't see his face well because it was dark. But he wore all black. He had red eyes and—"

A pause.

She cut her eyes to Izuku and studied him.

"…and blond hair," Himiko finished in a whisper.

"Not much of a description," Tomura said. He let out an exhausted exhale and finished writing down what Himiko said. He ripped out the page from his notepad, neatly folded it, and placed it into his pants pocket. He turned to Izuku with a deeply disapproving glare. "Izuku, go practice shooting at the range. You clearly need to sharpen your aim. Do that for the next ten hours."

"Yes, big brother," Izuku muttered.

"You two are dismissed," Tomura said in a short tone. "Try not to bother me for the rest of the evening."

Izuku stood up with his head still down. He bowed at the waist at the same time Himiko did and the two of them walked out of the office together.

Once outside of the stuffy room, Izuku exhaled and brushed his bangs out of his face. The skin on his cheeks felt like it was melting off from how flush he was. That was a close call, he realized. He knew Tomura covered for him for mainly self-preservation reasons, but Izuku was thankful that his safety was a side effect of Tomura's need to always look good in front of Nine.

He didn't bother to say goodbye to Himiko as he walked away, assuming she would ignore his existence like always. It wasn't until about halfway to the training facilities did Izuku realize she was still following him.

Izuku curiously peered over his shoulder.

Himiko gave him an uncharacteristic smile.

“Did you need something?” Izuku asked carefully.

“Let me help you at the shooting range,” Himiko said a little too sweetly. “I need to sharpen my aim as well.”

Alone with Himiko in the training facilities?

Izuku frowned and said, “uh, no thank you.”

He turned his head forward and walked a little quicker. But he internally groaned when the footsteps behind him kept up with his pace. Himiko put a skip in her step as she caught up and walked beside him. She tilted her head with a subtle saccharine charm.

“No, really. I can join you and help manage the mechanics,” Himiko pushed. “We’ll switch off after five hours. Think of it as my way of making sure you don’t screw up our next assignment together. I’m not doing this to be nice. I *promise*.”

Izuku wanted to tell her to go away—but when she hooked her arm on his, he knew she wouldn’t drop it. He sighed and told himself that it was *one* training practice. If she tried anything he could defend himself easily; she never beat him in sparring matches anyways.

“Alright, sure,” Izuku said, giving in all the way. “You can manage the machinery.”

Himiko smiled like she’d gotten the keys to a treasure trove.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Their shooting facilities were underground in the level above the punishment basement. It was a concrete fortress with rows and rows of practice ranges. Inside each room was a large space with various objects and obstacles to test how well they could shoot from complicated angles and scenarios.

But what made The Viper Academy’s shooting range unique was how it operated. Normal shooting ranges stocked sheets of paper with faceless silhouettes and lines on them to tell the shooter how accurate their bullet was.

On the other hand, viper shooting ranges were designed to weed out empathy.

Inside each practice range were realistic dummies of a wide variety. Old. Young. Tall. Short. Every type of physical form a human could take, the range accounted for it fifty times over. This was to ensure that all vipers could go for the kill no matter who it was.

There were options for how the dummies would appear. One option was the speed of the dummies appearing and disappearing. Fast. Slow. Medium pace. The next option was of age

and appearance. Old. Young. Brown eyes. Blue eyes. These options could be operated manually or automatically set.

Izuku usually chose ‘randomize’ and let the range be automatically operated.

Himiko took her place in the operating station. It was a tiny glass box suspended above the shooting range. She sat down, kicked her feet up on the control panel next to all the different buttons. While she gazed down, Izuku mechanically went through the motions as he put on the green shooting range gear. He treated this like any other training session as he loaded up the gun and cocked it.

He gave Himiko a thumbs up from the ground and she grinned.

The first dummy to appear was an elderly lady with gray hair. She was sweetly smiling in a pink dress.

Izuku easily shot a bullet through her skull.

The second dummy was of a young child of about the age of six. He had green eyes and curly purple hair.

Izuku shot him in the chest.

The third dummy was of a large man with dark brown hair and gray eyes.

Izuku shot him three times in the chest to account for his size.

This continued over and over until Izuku fell into a lull. He was operating purely from his muscle memory at this point as he emptied rounds of lead. The bodies appeared and he eliminated them just like how he was trained. He went through at least three clips of bullets until the next dummy came up.

This dummy had blond hair and green eyes.

Izuku hesitated ever so slightly. He furrowed his brow at the slip up but still shot through the skull.

Himiko ramped up the speed and numbers.

Five dummies popped up and one of them was blond. Izuku shot the other four first and there was a split second delay where he was able to shoot the blond dummy in the chest. Next, the speed increased. Izuku rapidly fired off his gun, reloading and cocking with viper level speed. More than fifteen dummies appeared at once now. Then twenty. Then thirty.

But in a short time all his movements were staggered.

One by one, each dummy slowly bled into having blond hair. Soon every blond dummy had red eyes.

Izuku stopped firing. Then all the color drained from his face. Dread sank into his spine like a rusted sword.

A sea of realistic dummies with red eyes and blond hair were staring back at him.

He carefully looked up at the control room.

Himiko smiled sickly. She silently chuckled behind the glass and waved.

Chapter End Notes

This is the last "Entr'acte" so be prepared to buckle in.

Next chapter is entitled "The Incident" and after that it'll steam roll right into the present story line. Since it's already written and edited, it'll be posted within a regular 2 weeks :) We're heading straight into hell, literally and figuratively :)

No preview because everything is a spoiler. Just think of how evil all Izuku's siblings are :^D Thank you so much! Lemme know what you think is going to happen for "The Incident"!! It's so exciting that we've finally arrived here after....350k words lol

Chapter 21: The Incident

Chapter Summary

First rule of snakes: never trust them.

Chapter Notes

Hellooooo! Welcome back to this very special chapter!!! Woooo! This is one I've been itching to write. I hope you all enjoy it and thanks for all your patience on this story! I'm having a ton of fun writing this. First, thank you to the LOML Luna for Betaing and being such an amazing sound board. She always pushes me to be my best angsty self.

Without further delay, enjoy!

Warnings: Extreme violence

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 21 — The Incident

.

.

.

Start of The Incident

Izuku didn’t finish the training session.

He hurried out of the training facilities like he’d been bitten by a real poisonous viper. Izuku could see Himiko begin to run too, and he snatched off the training gear as if it was suffocating him.

Izuku hated himself. He hated this place. He hated how he failed at keeping his *one* weakness concealed. Truly, he underestimated how overly observant Himiko was. She’d been keeping her eyes locked on him like a shark ready to pounce at the faintest whiff of blood—and she *succeeded*.

Himiko ran to Tomura to tell him what happened.

Right in step, Izuku did the same in an attempt to cover his own ass.

When they barged into Tomura's office, their older brother treated them like two children tattle telling on each other. But it was more than that. It was life or death—even if Tomura didn't know.

"Izuku has more than a preference for people with blond hair!" Himiko exclaimed. She frantically waved her hands up and down but Tomura's expression didn't seem like he cared. "The loose end also had blond hair! And now, in the shooting facilities, he hesitated on every single dummy that had blond hair!"

All of it strung together sounded outlandish.

It was like the words were floating without an anchor, Izuku noted. The center of the story was missing and because of that, her rant didn't *quite* make sense.

Tomura's brows furrowed together. He glanced between them not really understanding where this was going. He stayed silent, waiting for further explanation—but there was none.

Himiko knew nothing else. She kept repeating the same three points over and over until they lost their gravity. She wouldn't make sense until the *real* reason why Izuku hesitated with blond hair was uncovered.

When Himiko hit a wall while explaining, Izuku spoke up.

He stepped forward and blurted out the only thing that would slightly throw her off his scent:

"I've recently been sexually fantasizing about the model on the cover of my romance book," Izuku said quickly without taking a breath between words. "The model has red eyes and blond hair. That's why I have been so weird about it recently. I think that guy is handsome and I am fixated on him."

Tomura's whole expression became immediately exhaustive. He clasped his hands together and brought them up to his forehead to lean against.

He looked like he was praying for strength to deal with Izuku's idiocy.

Himiko stared at Izuku like he had finally lost it. But the twist in her face told Izuku she didn't believe him. Her cunning eyes narrowed as if she could smell the putrid lie on his lips. However, Izuku knew he didn't have to convince her—he only needed to convince Tomura.

Luckily, Tomura thought he was pathetic.

"You two are impossible," Tomura muttered. He exhaled roughly and shook his head. "I thought I told you to leave me alone for the rest of the day?"

Himiko's face dropped. She realized she was losing grip on the thin thread of truth she wrangled. She stammered, whirling on Izuku with a glare then back to Tomura.

She tried to say, "but *the blond hair*—" but it was no use.

“Save it,” Tomura cut down. He lifted a hand to stop her rambling and it curled into an impatient fist. “I am preparing for our next assignment with Chisaki. It’s extremely important so I don’t have time to dwell on Izuku’s strange *sexual preferences*.”

“I’m sorry for disturbing you, big brother,” Izuku said. He bowed and then decided to quickly switch the topics for his own sake. “What is the next assignment with Chisaki? If you don’t mind me asking.”

It was a perfect segue away from Izuku’s weakness.

Himiko was fuming beside him. She glared into his skull, but Izuku stared straight forward, ignoring her purposefully.

“We’re going to be escorting Chisaki Kai to the Tokyo Underground Council meeting,” Tomura said. “The six of us all together next week.”

Both Himiko and Izuku slightly stiffened.

The Tokyo Underground Council was extremely private. It was more of a myth than a real thing. Only a select few knew about it and even fewer knew *who* was on the council.

“That’s incredibly high ranked,” Himiko said seriously. Now her attention was hooked elsewhere. “Usually Nine handles all matters regarding the Underground Council.”

Tomura smirked and tilted his head. “Well, now I do.”

ᔓᔓᔓ

Himiko never really dropped the blond hair revelation. It was more so buried underneath their busy lives like a tiny needle in a haystack. But she was holding on to it in case she wanted to pull that needle out and stab Izuku in the eye with it.

Izuku on the other hand took a hard stance on the lie he told. He leaned into the fabrication about him having sex fantasies involving the random model with full force. He even asked Jin about how to stop sex dreams.

It was ridiculous enough that it seemed like he was telling the truth. Because what type of viper would admit to such a silly thing? No one on their unit listened to Himiko after that, dropping the strange fiasco all together.

The next week came and all talk of blond hair and red eyes were pushed aside.

Their new focus: The Tokyo Underground Council.

The Tokyo Underground Council was a shadowy network controlling their city.

It was a deadly, but invisible, spider web that connected all corners of organized crime in Japan. At the edges of it laid all the small criminals, wannabes, and mobsters. These were mainly the people who wanted to crawl their way to the center of the gold mine.

However, at the crux lay six pillars who held it all together. Izuku heard snippets about who these six people were. Each of the six pillars in the Underground Council used codenames to stop their true identities from spreading too far. This helped them remain illusive enough that none of their lives would be in danger.

Izuku had no clue who five of the six pillars were, but he knew one: Chisaki Kai.

Chisaki's power was historically unmatched. His reign over Tokyo started when he first took over his family's yakuza syndicate. Back then, it was only the Yamaguchi-gumi that he inherited. However, underneath his governorship, Chisaki was able to unify all the other major yakuza families in Japan into his own. It happened with all the grace of a blood soaked soap opera. Once he finished absorbing every inch of his rivals, what birthed was known as the Shie Hassaikai.

He gained the underground codename of Overhaul because of it.

Now that he controlled what is the largest criminal organization in history, he sat at the head of the Underground Council. He could say *jump*, and everyone would do it. But he could just as easily say *kill* and massacre an entire city.

And because of that, Chisaki Kai was The Viper Academy's number one client.

Izuku thought about all this as he walked behind Tomura.

His brother's shoulders were squared out in a way that was similar to a General who was leading a small army. Maybe he was, Izuku thought. He looked behind himself in that moment to see the rest of the Viper Seven unit following dutifully.

They were all dressed in their signature offensive fighting gear. Izuku sported his metal mask, covering the bottom half of his face. His sleeveless bodysuit was a deep viridian green and his twin fang daggers were hooked at his hips, their green tassels swayed with every step he took.

Tomura's favorite twin machetes were pinned to his back. He was dressed in all back tech wear with chains along the sides of his hips that sported various knives. Aoyama was wearing athletic leisure in blue hues and silver highlights.

Jin wore a simple, tight black shirt, dog tags and black and gray camo pants. In contrast to him, Himiko wore her favorite body suit that adorned two red lines running vertically along her sides. Then finally Ibara wore a perfectly crisp white jumpsuit with visors as she carried the briefcase full of various poisons.

They walked out of The Academy and down the narrow pathways in Tokyo. Immediately the people of Hadeus cleared the sidewalk for them as soon as they saw Tomura. Everyone's eyes bulged wide and quickly they bowed out of the way. It was curious. Izuku wondered when Tomura made such a reputation for himself.

Ibara sauntered to the front of the pack and walked beside Tomura. She turned to him and asked, "What is the meeting about today? It has to be really important to hire all six of us."

“The meeting is about the murder of one of the six pillars,” Tomura answered easily and everyone’s head perked up. “He was slaughtered fairly gruesomely from what the rumors are.”

“Do you know who it was?” Ibara asked in a low voice.

Tomura was quiet for a moment. Then he said, “I don’t. I know it was a man that had blond hair, that’s it but that could be anyone. It’s a common color.”

Everyone digested the information. How peculiar. After that they followed Tomura into a familiar restaurant. It was the place where Izuku caught Tomura having an overly friendly moment with One and Chisaki together.

Originally, Izuku didn’t think anything of this location being where the Underground Council might be meeting. It would make sense. However, he was proven a bit wrong when they walked in and Tomura didn’t stop for a table or a private room.

Instead, the hostess in the front saw them and quickly bowed her head. Tomura nodded at her, and it was then that Tomura pulled out a silver key from his pocket. Izuku followed his brother cautiously as he led them to a door in the backroom of the restaurant.

Using the key, Tomura unlocked it and revealed a large black elevator.

Tomura swiped his Viper Academy smartwatch on the keypad. The elevator activated, glowing bright white.

The door pulled open smoothly like it was brand new. The inside of the elevator shaft was all black and dark blue fluorescent lights rimmed the edges. When they all got into the elevator, Izuku noted there was only one button. It was black, sleek, and held no number. Tomura pressed it and it lit up blue.

The doors closed on them and no one spoke a word as they dropped down.

It felt like they were falling forever, honestly.

When the elevator shaft finally stopped and the doors jerked open, Izuku was hit with an unexpected wave of nostalgia .

His face shifted into pure shock.

All around were tall old, mythical-like pillars.

“Wait,” Izuku whispered. He walked out of the elevator and stared. “This is…”

“Yes.” Tomura wrapped an arm around Izuku’s shoulders and leaned down. His eyes were full of pride and mirth as he spoke. “This is your old pathway to the outside, Izuku. I owe you a big thank you for introducing this place to me all those years ago. Some good came from your delinquency.”

Izuku gazed on, struggling to comprehend what he was seeing.

The once abandoned flood system was now a fully functional underground city. Dozens, no, *hundreds* of people were weaving in and out down below like ants into newly crafted buildings.

The pillars were no longer a dull gray but a sleek black. Every pillar supported bridges, buildings, and balconies that all wove across each other like spiderwebs. The whole space was illuminated seductively with deep, dark colors such as maroon, mauve and sapphire.

All six Vipers stood next to each other on the balcony of the elevator. They looked down as a stray gust of wind from below bellowed upward.

“Welcome to the new Hadeus,” Tomura informed everyone. “It’s the official underground society come to life. I’ve been working with Chisaki to build this for the last ten years. This is the first level, limbo. In total there are nine levels, each going further down into the ground. To keep everything organized, each level is a different floor of operations and referred to as a ‘circle’.”

Izuku was transfixed.

This was incredibly intricate.

“Holy shit,” Himiko exclaimed in awe. “Would I be able to find a gambling spot here?”

“Yes,” Tomura said with a nod. “To find anything related to gambling, buying or trading you would go to the Fourth Circle: Greed.”

Jin gave a low whistle and curiously tilted his head. “What about sex things?” He mischievously asked. He grinned when Tomura frowned deeply and narrowed his eyes. “I know a place like this gotta have at least a dozen sex clubs.”

“…Second Circle: lust,” Tomura answered with a sharp, chastising tone. “Try not to let yourself indulge *too* much.”

“This is so cool,” Aoyama muttered. He gazed down at the sea of neon lights. “This is like a perfect paradise for people like us.”

“Precisely,” Tomura said. “We can exist here without judgment.”

Izuku became conflicted the longer he observed the new Hadeus.

This was a piece of his childhood that was attached to Kacchan. It was odd seeing the very place that brought him to the plaza of the broken angel twisted into something like this. A lot could change in a decade.

“What circle is the council meeting in?” Izuku asked quietly.

“The council will be meeting in the Sixth Circle,” Tomura answered. “That’s where we’re heading now, follow me.”

They all trailed behind Tomura as he walked down the stairs.

Then, they were fully immersed in the first circle of hell.

ᔓᔓᔓ

As they descended, Izuku began to see how unique each circle was.

The first circle, which was called Limbo, was more so for anything. People wandered around there looking sort of lost or searching to get into gangs. The buildings up there were a sanctuary for anyone who needed a place to sleep. Or even quick stops for operations that weren't terribly important.

By the time they reached the second circle, Izuku realized why Tomura answered Jin the way he did. It was a red light district with the same, vast structure as the first circle. All around were underground sex operations and sex workers. Pretty men and women beckoned to them as they passed by underneath the cardinal and fuchsia colored lights.

When they walked down further, they came across the third circle. The green lights flickered brightly above them with hints of yellowish and blue undertones. All around them were restaurants and banned substances that were illegal within Japan.

Their earpieces lost signal by the fourth circle underneath deep, golden lights.

It was here that Tomura posed a very important question. He would never have asked it if they weren't this far underground.

"How do you all feel about Nine?" Tomura asked. He clasped his hands behind his back and curiously glanced at them over his shoulder. "No need to bite your tongues, I won't tell him. This is private between us."

Izuku was taken back at the sheer gall.

Everyone else seemed to be as well based on their silence. But as it stretched on, the six of them exchanged speculative glances. In the corner of Izuku's mind, Hiryu's ghost joined them and studied them curiously.

Izuku didn't know what to say. He didn't *like* Nine but the fear inside of him instilled by their handler was something powerful. Talking down about Nine felt like they were trespassing on property that was bound to get them skinned.

"I respect him, I suppose," Himiko said with a shrug. "We don't really have much of a choice."

"Yeah." Aoyama nodded, agreeing with Himiko. "It's hard to like him but I respect him."

"Well I say fuck him," Jin spat. "I never really liked the guy. I think he gets off on torturing us in the basement."

Izuku and Ibara stayed quiet until Tomura turned his wintry gaze on them.

Ibara shifted on her feet. “I think he manages poorly,” she admitted. “We haven’t had any new kids in a long time and he should have figured out a way around that a while ago.”

“I agree with Ibara,” Izuku decided to say.

He truthfully didn’t. He was happy there were no other kids being sold to The Academy. He found a specific type of peace knowing the cycle might end with his cohort.

“Interesting,” Tomura muttered.

He sucked his teeth as if taste-testing what he was about to say.

“I have something I want to admit to you all as well,” Tomura continued. “I have been working with Chisaki privately without Nine’s permission or knowledge. It started about ten years ago when Nine let me accompany him on a mission with Chisaki.”

Everyone grew eerily quiet.

Private assignments off books? That was one of their taboos. They weren’t supposed to operate without their handler’s knowledge—yet here Tomura was doing it for ten years.

Izuku was both impressed and terrified.

“I saw a vision of a future for us back then,” Tomura said slowly. “I tried to tell Nine about my plans, but he dismissed me like a child. He said I was dreaming too big for someone who was a *Viper*. We’re supposed to be mindless weapons not leaders.”

“He’s not wrong,” Aoyama touched upon. “We are only assassins. That’s our purpose in life.”

“I know,” Tomura agreed. He nodded his head then tilted it as if seeing life from another angle. “But I want to be the leader of the Tokyo Underground Council one day—and I want to be more powerful than Nine himself. I want to make Vipers *more* than merely deadly assassins. I want to give us power and a position in the underground other than simply being useless men’s weapons.”

“Bold claim,” Jin said slowly. “How will you do that?”

“I…I don’t know yet,” Tomura admitted. This was the first time he ever sounded unsure. “I’ve become very close and friendly with Chisaki recently. He likes me more than he likes Nine, and he wants me to handle all cases involving him because of it. It didn’t make Nine happy—but he has to do what Chisaki says. I can find a way to power through Chisaki if I work with him long enough.”

“I kind of like the sound of this plan,” Ibara decided. She folded her arms seriously and her gaze grew solid. “What’s your next move then?”

“Well. Luckily someone brutally murdered one of the six pillars. Because of that, there’s an open spot available on the council now,” Tomura said. “Crime lords from all over the country are trying to bribe Chisaki or prove themselves in his eyes to get the seat. But I think I can obtain it.”

Himiko scoffed and announced, “Now you’re sounding ludicrous. You’re not a crime lord *and* you don’t have enough money to bribe the Yakuza heir with. How are you ever going to get that seat compared to all the other more qualified assholes gunning for it?”

Tomura shrugged.

“Not sure,” Tomura said. “The only thing I can think of is a trade. I have to find something Chisaki would want so *badly* that he would give me a place at the table in exchange for it.”

Izuku discarded everything Tomura said after that.

This was an unreachable dream. His brother was always the most driven of their family, so it shouldn’t surprise him that Tomura’s ambition went this far. He scored high on tests. He held the highest rank. He was the one who Nine trusted the most. It’s why every Viper admired him like he was a God amongst men, everyone was eager for his validation.

Tomura was a perfect Viper—but that’s all he was.

At the end of the day Tomura was a nobody who was sold into human trafficking like the rest of them.

He had no possessions that Chisaki didn’t already have a hundred times over.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When they finally reached the sixth circle, the lights surrounding them were all bright white. It was set up in a way that was clearly the circle of corporate operations. Everything here was perfectly neat in a way that Izuku could have mistaken the building they walked into for one in the Tokyo business district.

They met Chisaki in a small room that was underneath several locks and needed several keys.

The Yakuza Heir was dressed in an all gray pinstripe suit that made his golden eyes stand out. His skin was an unearthly type of pale and the hair on his head was a sleek reddish brown. Chisaki ran his long boney fingers over the expensive green faced Rolex on his wrist as someone next to him talked about various drug shipments to China.

He donned a bored, unfazed expression encompassing his sharp features when he finally acknowledged their presence.

Tomura bowed deeply at the waist. In sync, each of them lined up in numeric order according to their mark with Izuku standing at the end of the line. They all bowed at the same time and placed their arms behind their backs.

“Good evening, Mr. Chisaki,” Tomura said in a polite voice. “We’re here reporting for duty.”

When they all unbowed, Izuku saw Chisaki scan them up and down.

“Ah. My first time meeting The Viper Seven in person,” Chisaki said in a flat tone. His bored eyes roamed their unit. Then he raised one of his arched brows suspiciously. “There’s only six of you.”

“Obsidian Viper is on a permanent assignment overseas,” Tomura answered fluidly. “He won’t be joining us.”

“What a fuckin’ liar,” Hiryu’s phantom groaned. He unhappily huffed in the darkest corner.

“Shame,” Chisaki muttered. “I was hoping to see all my merchandise today considering how much I paid. The price for the full unit made me go to another company to see if they might be cheaper, but atlas, no one really offers the same level of training as The Academy.”

“We’re always thankful for your patronage,” Tomura said with a fake smile. “Glad no one can beat out our impeccable skill set.”

Chisaki strolled by them carrying an air of languor.

He assessed each one of them without haste and also without interest. Izuku knew this man was entirely disinterested in them. To him, they were merely wallpaper to be plastered in the background for this meeting. Izuku supposed they were only a form of deadly decoration in comparison to how much influence Chisaki possessed.

When Chisaki strolled by Izuku, Izuku was expecting him to keep going like he’d done for the rest of their unit.

However, when Chisaki passed him the man stopped.

He backtracked slightly, and did a double take. A small spark of interest bled into his face as he cut his eyes at Izuku.

Izuku stiffened underneath the yellow gaze.

From the front of the line, Tomura turned his head towards the interaction.

“Freckles,” is all Chisaki said with a curious tint. “I don’t think we’ve met before. I’m guessing you’re the Viridian Viper?”

Izuku nodded dutifully. “I am, sir.”

Chisaki tilted his head at Izuku. “What’s your real name?”

Izuku was taken back. He turned his eyes to Tomura for a clue of what to do. His brother was staring hard with his lips in a thin line. Slowly, Tomura walked over and stood behind Izuku like a looming shadow. Tomura sat both his hands on Izuku’s smaller shoulders with a protective grip.

“His name is Izuku,” Tomura answered for him in a powerful voice. “He’s *my* little brother.”

Chisaki cut his eyes to Tomura.

Izuku didn't have to see his brother to know he was giving his signature stare of dominance. Chisaki nodded, as if approving of the name, then he reached forward to tap the metal mask on Izuku's face.

"Can we remove this for the night? It feels suffocating," Chisaki said.

Izuku thought for certain his brother was going to say 'no'. It was Izuku's safety net to hide his emotions that he could barely keep a lid on. But to Izuku's surprise, Tomura removed his hands from his shoulders and unclasped the mask. He gingerly removed it from Izuku's face and then brushed a stray curl behind his ear.

Izuku's heart rate sped up. He felt inexplicably nude.

"Incredible. Your face is perfectly symmetrical," Chisaki whispered in awe. "I've never seen this level of exquisiteness before."

Chisaki drew close, getting personal. Izuku stayed as still as a statue like he was trained as Chisaki reached up and grabbed his chin. Chisaki turned his head side to side much like Nine in the past.

"He is quite beautiful, isn't he?" Tomura agreed.

Chisaki glanced down at the daggers attached to Izuku's hip. He reached and grabbed one of the swinging tassels and caressed it lightly.

"Deathly so," Chisaki agreed with an air of intrigue.

Izuku relaxed his arms, breaking his stance. His limbs fell to his side and the motion brought Chisaki's eyes down to his arms.

Suddenly the glimmer of admiration left as quickly as it came. Chisaki's lips curled over his teeth and he reeled his head back. He took a generous step away.

The sudden cold switch confused Tomura and Izuku.

It was then Izuku and Tomura both followed Chisaki's line of sight.

Chisaki was staring in disgust at the damage Tomura inflicted on Izuku from various sessions of 'punishments'. Izuku's arms were littered with blue, purple, and even some yellow bruises. Jagged cuts and scrapes from assignments were layered across the bruises. However, what stood out the most were the angry, red welts from where Tomura had beaten him fiercely with the belt over and over and over.

"A battered beauty, what a shame," Chisaki muttered like he was disillusioned. "Such ugly marks too. You were nearly perfect."

Chisaki gave a long, disappointed exhale. He fell back into his bored demeanor and turned away from Izuku like the whole interaction never happened.

Izuku didn't think much of it and wrote it off as weird rich-guy behavior. Chisaki wasn't the first person to comment on his looks and he wouldn't be the last.

"Well, the meeting will start shortly," Chisaki announced. With a single head nod he signaled for his secretary to grab the clipboard and pen. "We should be heading over to that part of the building now to ensure we'll be on time."

All the Vipers slipped directly into their killer personas.

Everyone except Tomura, that is.

Instead, Tomura studiously glanced between Izuku, Chisaki, and the bruises on Izuku's skin.

He pursed his lips to the side and the gears in his head turned.

The room where the council was meeting was grand and golden. The rug that spread across the floor was full of delicate, organic designs. He looked closely at the woven birds and wondered how expensive this thing was.

On top of that rug was a medium sized table that held six chairs. There was a single chair at the head of the table.

They walked around Chisaki and his secretary in the formation of a protective circle with their weapons drawn as he took his seat. Tomura took his stance next to Chisaki's chair and signaled for the rest of them to line up behind their client's seat.

Like a storm, in came the other four pillars.

They were some of the most dangerous yet intelligent looking individuals. They all walked in with at least five to ten guards, and the aura around them was untouchable. Judging by the amount of weapons strapped to everyone, Izuku knew not a soul in this room trusted each other.

The first person to walk in was a lanky ginger man with a pointy nose. His codename was Re-Destro. His eyes were a dull green and his hairline was receding in an M shape. He was dressed in an expensive green suit and copper jewelry. He lit a fat cigar between his boney fingers as he took his seat.

The next person was a young woman with gorgeous brown skin and long lilac hair. Her codename was revealed to be Curious. Her flowy hair swayed as she walked in with a glamorous, long navy blue dress. She puffed up the expensive fur shawl on her shoulders as her turquoise eyes surveyed the room.

The third person to walk in was a tall woman with deep red hair. Her hair reached to her waist and her bangs were cut at chin-length. Her codename was said to be Slice. Her skin was glossy and looked healthy. But along her thighs were knives and her purple dress was decorated in sharp weapons.

The last person to walk in caught Izuku's eye.

It was a tall, built man with sleek black hair. Around his neck was a necklace made of human molars and on his back was a long rusted katana embedded with blood stains. His cunning eyes were like bullseyes as he took the time to assess everyone. His codename was known to be Stain.

All four people took their seats. They skipped hellos and began the meeting when Chisaki folded his hands.

Izuku originally zoned out for the first three hours of the meeting.

The five pillars talked about operations in extreme code. Any location was referred to as a fruit, and within their sentences the pillars used random latin terms such as sepelio, excessum and letum. It all made sense why Tomura pushed to learn Latin so long ago.

It wasn't until about half way through the meeting did Izuku catch a bit of the convo that hooked his attention.

"My entrapment with the bribes didn't work," Stain barked. The large man wrinkled his face and balled his fist up. "That brat is more of a savage brute than I would have guessed. He spat on my Persian rug like he was raised by goddamn wolves."

"So he's hotheaded. I guess it's genetic," Chisaki muttered. He still looked bored as he leaned his head in his hand. "Did you get the information on him I asked for?"

"Yes, I did." Stain snapped his fingers and one of his men stepped forward.

Stain's lackey revealed a black folder that was brimming with documents. It was lofty and slightly disorganized. The lackey walked it over to Chisaki with an anxious expression, clearly terrified of the Yakuza Heir. Izuku resisted the urge to strain his neck to see what was inside, his view was obstructed by Chisaki's large chair.

"I must say I am delightfully shocked by what we uncovered," Stain said with a chuckle. "I think you'll be interested in bringing in the brat. We could mold him to be one of the most ruthless crime lords in history. He has the greatest bloodlust I've ever seen in someone so young."

"I have no interest in that," Chisaki said. His eyes remained uninterested as he plucked a flimsy photograph from the folder. He held it up and tilted his head to the side. "This right here is what I am interested in."

Izuku wished he could see what the photograph was based on all the confused reactions.

"Her?" Stain frowned. "She's merely some random gambling addict. What about the fact that brat is *that* dead bastard's *son*?"

Stain angrily gestured to the empty seat next to him.

“Pointless information given this kid is about to be an orphan,” Chisaki muttered. “I almost feel sorry for him for having such a terrible set of parents.”

Curious spoke up now. She jutted her chin to the photograph in Chisaki’s hand. “So you’re planning on killing the mother, Overhaul?”

“Yes, I am,” Chisaki answered with no inflection.

“Why, might I ask?” Slice butted in. She frowned as she looked between Chisaki and the photo. “This doesn’t seem very much like you.”

“It’s not like me, honestly. But this whole thing is troublesome,” Chisaki answered. “I loaned this woman about a million yen and sheltered her in a Yakuza safe house. She was hiding from child protective services and told me she left her kid with a relative in the meantime. I took pity on her. But then she proceeded to steal my dead grandmother’s *pearls* from underneath me and fled without repaying her debts.”

“Sounds like a petty crime,” Slice said.

“Debts are debts,” Chisaki firmly reminded her. “That is our motto and we should start enforcing it.”

“How long ago was this?” Curious asked.

“It was about thirteen years ago,” Chisaki answered then shrugged. “No one remembers it. But I figured I would clip this loose end while I have the chance. The sixth pillar always let too many things slide and who’s to say his death isn’t the fruition of his sloppiness.”

“Allow me to kill the brat’s mother for you then,” Stain offered. He snidely smiled as he placed his hand above his heart. “He made a mockery of me. My people are waiting for me to teach him a lesson.”

Chisaki broke his relaxed demeanor and frowned. His eyes narrowed on Stain, and everyone else stiffened.

“Are you asking me to help save your reputation because you decided to make a sloppy show?” Chisaki asked.

“Yes,” Stain clarified with mild hesitation. He cleared his throat awkwardly. “It’s a matter of optics. I’m sure you understand.”

“I *don’t*,” Chisaki cut down in a clipped tone. “I think the way you handle things is as sloppy as our dead ally. Given how your failed entrapment of his kid went, It would be foolish to entrust this to you. I’ll give it to a Viper instead. They always get the job done—you? Not so much.”

It was obvious Stain was resentful of that answer.

He dug his gaze into Chisaki for a second too long.

All the Vipers in the room reached for their weapons and in turn all of Stain's henchmen reached for theirs. The tension in the air spiked to new degrees as the murderous intent dripped all over the floor.

Stain then wearily glanced at the The Vipers surrounding Chisaki.

When Tomura's face darkened into a lethal glower like a cobra, Stain reluctantly bowed his head.

"Of course, Overhaul," Stain muttered. "My apologies for asking."

All the Vipers relaxed their stances and shortly after so did Stain's henchmen.

Chisaki turned his nose up and shook his head like he was dealing with a spoiled brat.

"May I propose that Stain take credit for the kill?" Curious suggested. She smiled sweetly as she leveled with their leader. "Optics *are* important. No one knows this woman owes you money but everyone knows this kid openly disrespected Stain. If we are to keep our allyship strong, we have to make sure we look unforgiving to the public eye. Otherwise we'll begin to look collectively weak."

Chisaki thought about it for a moment.

Then he waved his hand as if he didn't want to dwell on the topic any further.

"Sure," Chisaki said without much concern. "I suppose that's fine. As long as she's dead I don't care who takes credit."

Stain perked up.

A grotesque smile encompassed his shadowy features.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When the meeting ended Chisaki made them wait inside of a small room with him.

It was an off-site office space for Yakuza business. Inside the room were the bare minimum utilities. A printer. A chair. A shelf and a window to see the underground sixth circle. Chisaki sat at a large mahogany desk as he wrote down something and off to the side his secretary was typing on their laptop.

As they waited in silence, Tomura's arms were folded. A small furrow creased his brows as he stared at the welts along Izuku's arms. Izuku didn't think much of it, but he was beginning to feel self-conscious underneath Tomura's calculating gaze.

Tomura probed his tongue into his cheek as his eyes roamed up and down Izuku's figure.

"Vipers," Chisaki suddenly called, snapping them all into formation. Chisaki's secretary stepped forward holding a thin, simple red folder. "I have a new assignment ready for you—specifically for Blood Viper."

Himiko stepped forward and bowed.

“Please make sure the scene is clean,” Chisaki said. His secretary handed Himiko the folder gently. “I don’t want it tied back to me since Stain is going to take credit for this.”

Himiko nodded dutifully and stepped back in line. She thumbed quickly through the folder then paused at something. Himiko cut her eyes to Izuku. She then stood up straight, closed the folder quickly, and cleared her throat.

“I think this would be a better job for the Viridian Viper,” Himiko said. “He’s the better poison sniper between the two of us. I can still accompany him though. Two Vipers are always better than one.”

All the Vipers in the room looked at her oddly then glanced at Izuku.

Izuku frowned, baffled. What was her angle?

He stared at her, but she didn’t give him the satisfaction of a single bit of attention. She clutched onto the red folder tightly as she looked straight forward.

Chisaki raised a thin brow at the two of them. Then he looked at Tomura.

“Is that true?” Chisaki asked.

Tomura was hesitant, but still nodded. “Yes. Izuku is the better sniper between the two.”

“Alright, fine,” Chisaki agreed, then turned to his secretary with a small nod. “Change it over to Viridian Viper.”

The secretary stepped forward, took the red folder from Himiko and drew up a new form. He made amends to have the case switched over from Himiko to Izuku. Then he walked to hand it to Izuku—but Himiko grabbed a hold of it.

“I’ll hold it,” Himiko said kindly. “My baby brother has delicate hands.”

Himiko’s golden gaze pierced through Izuku. A falsely sweet smile spilled upon her lips, and she earned several peculiar glances.

Suddenly, the ghost of Hiryu was hanging over his shoulder, casting a cold shadow.

ɯɯɯ

Night before The Incident

The entire train ride to Yokohama, Himiko ignored him.

He looked at her sideways as they departed for their assignment. She didn’t give him anything other than a tight smile as she privately read the details and instructed them where to go.

Anytime he tried to force her to crack, she sneered.

“Show me the folder, Himiko,” Izuku said sternly once they were a couple stops away from Yokohama.

“There’s no need,” she quipped. She dug some dirt from under her thumbnail. “You don’t even like looking at the folder details. Why do you want to know?”

“Because you’re acting strange,” Izuku said. “And I don’t trust you.”

At that, Himiko laughed.

“I’m only here to accompany you, don’t worry,” Himiko reassured. She kicked her feet up in the seat across from her. “I want to make sure you don’t screw up like last time. I’m watching you closely.”

Izuku leaned back in the chair and crossed his arms. He decided to just let whatever she was playing at take its course. She didn’t know *exactly* why he didn’t pull the trigger last time. Plus, they were sniping someone from a long distance.

What could possibly go wrong?

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku walked onto the rickety rooftop with caution.

The tiles underneath his feet were unstable and clearly neglected. In the dead of night there were hundreds of windows in range from this vantage point. Izuku kept himself peeled for whatever Himiko might pull. He carefully studied her as he set up his sniper rifle. She smiled at him right back holding the folder.

“Which one is it?” Izuku asked impatiently.

Himiko smiled with fever. She pointed slowly across the way with a long, slender finger.

“That one,” she said in a lilting voice. Izuku followed her finger to a small window. Yellow light was pouring from it. It was the only window with a light in the expensive apartment complex.

Izuku took his stance.

He kneeled down on the jagged rooftop and gripped his rifle. He tilted his head and peered through the bullseye. He scanned for the target—

—and his heart dropped when he was met with a strange visual.

On the couch was a woman with scarlet red eyes and ash blonde hair.

Izuku snatched himself backwards and whipped his head at Himiko.

His devious sister smiled back at him.

“This isn’t the time to play games with me,” Izuku hissed. “Chisaki is not the person we can screw up assignments for. Where is the real mark?”

“I’m not playing any games,” Himiko informed. “This *is* the mark.”

She then plucked a picture from the red folder and turned it around with two fingers.

Izuku stood up and snatched it from her. He looked at the photograph, trying to tell himself it wasn’t real. But it was. The exact same woman on the couch was in this photo. She was carrying a bundle of pink carnations with a bright smile on her face. But worse, she had a lopsided type of smile. One that felt eerily symmetrical to Kacchan’s.

Himiko smirked when all the color washed away from Izuku’s face.

“I told you. She’s the mark,” Himiko said, rubbing it in. She continued to read the address out loud to him, confirming this was the correct location. When she finished, she snapped the folder shut and smiled with a glimmer of satisfaction. “Now, take the shot.”

Izuku swallowed and stilled his nerves.

His gaze hardened as he turned his attention back through the bullseye. He positioned himself with perfect aim. One bullet. One bullet. That’s all it would take. He looked at the woman who was snuggled into her couch. She was eating a bowl of popcorn and rotating puffing on a cigarette. Around her neck were the pearls Chisaki mentioned.

Izuku tried to move his finger on the trigger, but instead it ran ice cold.

Fear began swelling inside of him.

Himiko squatted directly next to him and leaned in.

“I said, take the shot, Izuku,” she commanded slowly.

Izuku exhaled through his nose as he told himself the same thing. He could do it. He *could*—but the longer he looked at the mark the longer he felt like he saw Kacchan. He then thought he hallucinated a potential resemblance with the stranger. Suddenly, it wasn’t one red string wrapped around his heart—it was two.

He attempted to pull the trigger a second time and saw Kacchan smiling at him in the nook.

He attempted to pull the trigger a third time and saw the handsome stranger smiling at him in Vienna.

Izuku grew more and more distraught every time he failed to pull the trigger. Each instance he was stopped by the clenching in his chest. He was bombarded with a tango of scarlet red eyes boring into him. Abruptly, his heart felt like it was collapsing under weight. Izuku struggled to breathe and the sinister presence of Himiko next to him made him slowly panic.

She knew.

“I think I finally found your weakness, baby brother,” Himiko chuckled darkly.

Izuku began to shake. He reeled back with his eyes wide.

“Please,” Izuku said. He slowly shook his head, begging for an ounce of mercy. “You know. Fine, but I can’t—I can’t *do it*—”

“Why red eyes and blond hair?” She pushed. “Why does that specific combo fuck with you?”

“*Himiko*,” Izuku warned from between his teeth. “Please. Leave this alone.”

His eyes dangerously darkened.

“Y’know, I thought about this after the training session,” she said. She tilted her head while her eyes darkened the same way as Izuku. “I couldn’t quite figure it out at first. I did believe all that bullshit about the model originally. But the more I thought about it—I kept thinking about that loose end. *Especially*—how he looked at you from that train window.”

“What are you getting at?” Izuku cut off.

“He looked at you like he knew you,” Himiko spat. “Like if you pulled the trigger it would be a betrayal.”

“Don’t do this,” Izuku pleaded.

“Oh, I’m going to do this and *more*,” she said happily. “I couldn’t shake the feeling about that loose end. So I decided to go digging for information—so I got Aoyama black out drunk. I figured I would go straight to who you’re closest with to see what’s going on. But Imagine my surprise when he blabbed about him and Tomura having to forge documentation for you. You have missed *dozens* of marks.”

Izuku’s heart dropped straight to the floor.

“Do you know what happens to vipers that cross Nine, Izuku?” Himiko asked.

The coldness from Izuku’s trigger finger crept up. It spread from his hand to his arm, and deep into his veins until Izuku felt like his bones were crafted of very fragile ice.

“They die,” Himiko said with delight.

Izuku’s shaking grew steadily like a building earthquake until all the dreadful moments compiled. With glee, Himiko pushed him out the way and took a hold of the sniper rifle. He stumbled backwards and stared in horror at her. His body was paralyzed because she knew about the documentation forging.

She cocked the weapon—something Izuku failed to do.

She kneeled into position as she smirked at him.

“I’m going to have a fun time informing Chisaki that your defect prevented you from taking the shot,” Himiko said. “Then I’m going to have a goddamn field day exposing you, Tomura and Aoyama’s little facade. I feel like Nine will spare Tomura because well, he’s Tomura. Aoyama will probably be demoted and no longer trusted with company records. But you—*as defected as you are*—he’s going to exterminate you.”

She grinned as she turned her attention to the window.

She looked through the bullseye and put her finger over the trigger.

“I hope you enjoy your fall from grace, Izuku. Because when you land, it’ll be in a coffin.”

Izuku couldn’t say what came over him. He knew his mental block was strong, but what happened next felt like slow motion.

Himiko moved her trigger finger.

In a flash, Izuku envisioned her shooting Kacchan through the heart.

His body moved on its own and he plunged forward. He dived directly into her and the gun. The rifle tilted up, firing the bullet straight into the sky. At the same instance, Himiko and Izuku went tumbling into the loosened tiles of the roof. Her head hit the hard surface with a sharp crack and the skin on Izuku’s palms was scraped off against the uneven surface.

He hissed in pain and jerked his head behind him. His eyes widened when the rifle went toppling over the edge off the roof. It hit the ground with a shattering sound. He then snapped his head to look beneath him and there was Himiko—nearly knocked out.

Izuku’s breath caught as he stared at her limp body.

He carefully turned her over to inspect her head damage, fearful of the worse.

But before he could look, a loud groan echoed into the night. He retreated his hand and Himiko’s eyes slowly blinked open. Her head swayed as she struggled upright on her forearms. Her eyes were wide as Izuku scrambled away from her.

She touched the back of her head. When her hand pulled back, there was dark crimson blood oozing down her fingers.

They stared at each other in shock.

The wind howled loudly. Izuku swore he heard the faintest bit of Hiryu’s voice come with it.

“*Run*,” Hiryu whispered.

Izuku did.

Izuku took off in the direction of the exit as if the wind was carrying his feet. Several bullets went flying by his head and he ducked the best he could. A scolding hot bullet nicked his pocket, and the impact made him hiss out loud.

He made a mad dash for the door, and successfully locked it behind him. A loud pounding on the door followed mimicking booming thunder. Himiko's shrill voice was like lightning cracking in their ever growing storm.

Suddenly, Izuku could hear Himiko call someone—and he knew it wouldn't be Tomura.

Izuku then tried to call Tomura to warn him about what Himiko knew. He reached for his pocket but was mortified to find his phone impacted with a bullet. He desperately tapped the shattered screen and tried to turn on the device but it was no use. It was as dead as he was.

"Hello? Nine?" Izuku then heard Himiko say.

Izuku's heart plummeted.

He didn't stay to hear the conversation.

He backed away from the steel door and retreated down the empty building. He didn't know how much time he gave himself, but he knew it wasn't much. From up above he heard Himiko shoot the lock clean off the door and slam it open.

Izuku used all his stamina training as he jumped down the stairs to land on his feet with staggering impact. He ran out a side door of the abandoned building and straight into a dark alley. Faintly behind him he could hear Himiko chasing him.

Giving himself more speed, Izuku zig zagged around several corners and narrow pathways. With every corner that he turned he saw Hiryu's phantom standing in the darkest shadows, bleeding out of the bullet holes Izuku put in his body.

His mind was pounding with panicked thoughts.

He screwed up beyond Tomura being able to fix this. What's worse, he got Tomura and Aoyama mixed up in his defect. Panic captured Izuku's heart as he tried his best to outrun the grim reaper over his shoulder. He tried to think of scenarios this could play out in his favor but he knew there would be none—

—Sudden, hot pain swelled in Izuku's inner thigh.

Izuku hissed out loud and stumbled on his feet at the sensation.

He leaned against a dirtied brick wall in confusion. He panted heavily as he gripped his thigh.

"Fuck," he hissed. "Why now?"

Izuku cursed himself for potentially pulling a muscle or pinching a nerve in *this* type of moment.

With impatience, Izuku kneaded into the spot to ease the pain. He wearily gazed over his shoulder, feeling the clock ticking on him.

To his dismay, the pain didn't go away—it grew.

Izuku heard Himiko's footsteps get close. He sucked in a deep breath and took off again.

Memories of Hiryu's cold, dead body hovered close to him. He could feel the clammy skin of his deceased brother pressed against him with every step he took. He ducked quickly through a maze of allies into a sketchier part of the city that had a darkly tinted nightlife.

Izuku knew a gangster when he saw one, and he could see several as he came to the mouth of one narrow pathway. He found himself in what felt like a secret club scene as several eyes were on him.

Izuku didn't waste time. He ran past all the curious goons towards the nearest ally.

Izuku looked behind him for a split second—then came to a crashing halt when he collided with someone.

Him and the person went flying down into the pavement and both of them groaned loudly. Izuku hissed, arching his back at the pain. The heat in his thigh was increasing, slowly becoming numbing.

He frantically opened up his eyes to see soft, pink carnation petals raining down like soft snow. Izuku turned to see his blond stranger holding a now ruined bouquet of pink carnations. Both of their hair was littered with the gentle flower petals. Izuku quickly gazed past the stranger, chest heaving.

For the first time in his life, Izuku didn't care about seeing this man.

The stranger groaned and sat up on his forearms. He grabbed his head and shook it.

"What the actual fuck?" The deep voice barked. "Watch where you're going *dumbass*—"

Piercing red eyes snapped up to glare at him.

"Deku?!" The stranger hissed immediately. "Oh, fuck no. You're not messing up my assignment tonight. I have places to be in the morning—"

The stranger immediately pulled out his knife and swung it. Izuku, stunned at the action, quickly put his hand up in defense. He moved too late and the sharp knife cut through his skin, gashing his palm deeply. Izuku yelled and curled his hand into his chest.

The stranger stopped mid-second-swing the second they locked eyes.

Izuku's bloodshot eyes pleaded with him in silence. The stranger looked at him, taking in his terrified, disheveled appearance. The blood that was dripping from Izuku's skinned palms smeared across his forearms and all over his clothes.

Izuku took a moment to frantically try to stand up right, but stumbled. The pain in his leg was growing and Izuku couldn't figure out *why*.

Izuku looked past the stranger, and the stranger glanced behind himself wearily.

Izuku knew Himiko was still behind him, but not that far. He decided to not take the chance of her catching up to him. Izuku pushed through the radiating pain in his thigh and took off running again. He was stumbling and he tried his best to reach the next street.

Suddenly a strong hand grabbed him by his elbow. He was dragged into a narrow pathway that held another dark corner. The space was too tight to walk through and far too small for two people. Their bodies slotted together in a singeing closeness in the darkness. Quickly, the stranger clasped a hand over his mouth to muffle his ragged breathing.

Seconds passed and Izuku could hear Himiko's footsteps speed past.

Their chests breathed in and out in sync. Izuku's eyes were wide with fear. His hands were clammy with anxiety. Only when Himiko's footsteps faded into the background did Izuku glance at the stranger. The stranger's scarlet eyes were unnaturally bright in the darkness, like they were illuminated with all his passionate hatred for Izuku.

Izuku then registered that he was tightly holding onto the stranger's shirt. But Izuku couldn't let go.

As if the stranger could tell Izuku was scared of something—or someone—he peaked around the corner.

"First off, are you here on an assignment to kill some drug lord named Daiki?" The stranger asked carefully. "Because if you are, I'm contractually bound to stop you."

"N-No," Izuku responded truthfully. He shook his head fast. "I'm not. I swear. I-I need to get out of this city."

The stranger then cut his eyes down to the blood covered bruises on Izuku's arm.

He then maneuvered their bodies out of the tight space. They both carefully looked around before swiftly fading into the darkness of the back passageways. The stranger was dragging Izuku by his elbow further and further into the darkness.

Izuku's viper was telling him he was making a mistake letting this man drag him to some dark corner—he could kill him.

But an inkling of Izuku trusted him.

"The waterway passage underneath Yokohama leads out to the city limits," the stranger informed him. He let go of Izuku and bent down to lift up the heavy lid on a manhole. He gritted his teeth and dragged it to the side. "It'll spit you out into a river."

"Wh-Which way is the opposite direction of Tokyo?"

"To the right. Keep making rights and you'll end up in Kamakura."

The sound of footsteps suddenly drew close and Izuku's blood ran cold. He knew all his siblings' footsteps by heart—and those were Himiko's coming near.

The stranger could see the panic paint across his face. The stranger also looked over his shoulder and began hurriedly guiding Izuku down. He helped lower Izuku into the water system, until his feet hit the underground stream that waded up to his thigh.

Izuku hissed at the absorbed impact that shot up his leg. The pain was now radiating into his whole upper thigh. Izuku looked up from the dark tunnel above to see beautiful red eyes.

The stranger nodded at him and dragged the lid for the manhole back in place, shutting him in.

Izuku listened for the stranger to run away. Next, Izuku pressed himself against the underground wall as he heard Himiko's footsteps come to a skidding halt. She stopped right above him. She slowed, staring around and checking the area. But when she couldn't find him, she cursed out loud.

Izuku held his breath as she ran back the direction she came.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Morning of The Incident

By sunrise Izuku's entire leg was numb.

He was moving slowly. He was lugging the appendage along as if it was dead. Izuku was worried it was because the pain felt like it was searing through his flesh. He groaned as he worked his way through the dirty water, face pinched at the putrid smell. He hoped the stranger was right about this and not dragging him through literal shit for the hell of it.

During his journey, Izuku was trapped in shock. He was shocked at what Himiko knew.

But worse, he was shocked he possessed a reflex to stop a kill.

From here on out, Izuku knew his life would fall apart right into a casket. Himiko was right. Nine would punish Aoyama and Tomura but he would kill Izuku for being so deeply defective.

All the pieces of his half baked life crumbled like paper before his eyes.

But it was nearly a matter of time, wasn't it? Tomura had been covering for him since he was eight. Now he is twenty. It was bound to catch up with him and strike him in the jugular. He didn't guess Himiko would be the one holding the knife when the time came. There were legitimate grounds to say he attacked Himiko with that head wound. Not only that, he was guilty of helping forge documentation, being defective, and *lying*.

If he went back to The Academy now, Nine would give the command to exterminate him.

On this lonely excursion, Izuku knew he would miss his siblings.

But most of all, Izuku realized he didn't want to die.

A flicker inside of him wanted to experience the life he always dreamed about as a child. One with a family. One with a lover and he wondered if he could buy himself two years of paradise after twenty years of hell. Izuku didn't want to die by Himiko's hands. He thought about how Hiryu had gotten away—not for long—but maybe Izuku could buy himself some time.

Maybe he could even look for Kacchan now, he thought dangerously.

That thought alone gave him a second wind.

Izuku turned another corner and suddenly was flooded with a blinding white light.

He put his throbbing hand up to shield his sore eyes. He sighed in relief for finally getting to the exit and dragged himself towards the light. He used the walls to support himself.

He reached the opening of the waterway and exactly like the stranger promised, it led out to a large river. Izuku sucked in a deep breath and plunged into the body of water. The cold water hit his skin and he relished the breath of fresh air as the stench of the waterway was rinsed off of him.

Izuku swam weakly to the surface and over to the edge. His fingers dug into the wet earth and pulled himself up with all his grit.

Izuku breathed out heavily as he dragged his body onto the field of grass. All around him were tiny dandelions swaying with the morning breeze, tiny seeds flying off with the gust of the wind. Izuku lobbed his head as he tried his best to catch his breath.

He gazed at the beautiful sunset like it was a new beginning and tears of slight happiness gathered in his eyes.

He turned his head over his shoulder to see the distant skyline of Yokohama. He silently thanked the stranger in his head. It was then Izuku knew he would miss one more person if he was to escape this lifestyle.

Izuku began to pull himself onto his feet when the sound of a single sigh stopped him.

Everything in his body ran cold.

"Once again, you're crawling through tunnels you shouldn't be," Tomura's voice drawled. "You really never change, do you?"

Izuku's head slowly turned in disbelief.

To his horror, Tomura was sitting cross legged on top of the exit of the tunnel. It was as if he was waiting for him this whole time. He was dressed in the same clothes from the day before.

"H-How?" Izuku asked, voice cracking.

"I have my ways," Tomura said angrily.

Tomura slid off the tunnel and stood in front of Izuku. He stepped unkindly on Izuku's injured hand with his leather boot.

Izuku hissed as he tried to retract his hand, but Tomura dug into him further.

"I asked Chisaki for a photograph of the mark after Himiko began acting strange," Tomura revealed. He put his hands into his trench coat pockets and tilted his head. "Red eyes and blonde hair. The same thing Himiko kept rambling on about. I decided to tail you two after that and keep a close eye in case anything happened. I guess I was right to do so."

Izuku's voice splintered with a sob.

Any hope he conjured of a different life slipped away as quickly as it came.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Tomura dragged him back to that rooftop and his numb leg protested the whole way.

It was the middle of the day now, and the sun was shining terribly bright for such a moment. Izuku thought for sure maybe Tomura would kill him before Nine could. Maybe this would be Tomura's last possessive act as his caretaker: ending his life.

The dried blood from where Himiko hit her head was caked on the roof. It looked like it was scrubbed but the jagged tiles were too tattered to purge all the cracks.

They both looked at the distant window and the silhouette of the woman inside. She was vacuuming while singing and dancing.

Tomura's hand touched his back too gently and all too threateningly.

"Do you know her?" Tomura asked carefully.

"No," Izuku said.

He clenched his fists when Tomura began pushing him closer to the edge. It was subtle but his feet moved with every second closer and closer to the fall off.

"Then why can't you kill her?" Tomura asked.

Izuku's breathing became erratic. He tried to nudge the words off his tongue but they stayed glued down against his will. Tomura snarled and pushed him hard until his toes were directly on the slippery edge.

"Izuku. Either you tell me what's going on right *now* or I push you over this edge and save us both trouble."

Izuku's instinct to survive kicked in. "I-I…I can't pull the trigger when someone…has red eyes and blond hair."

Tomura sucked at his teeth. His hand switched from lightly pushing him to clutching his shirt.

"*Why*?" Tomura hissed. He pushed Izuku closer to the edge but used his strength to hold him on the angle. "Tell me right fucking *now*."

Izuku's footing slipped slightly on the incline. Panic surged through him.

"Wh-When I snuck out—those tw-two years," Izuku said quickly. He wept through clenched teeth. "I-I met a boy with red eyes and blond hair."

"I love you Kacchan," Izuku heard his younger self say as he wrote the tiny note. He could feel the same tears slip out his eyes now as he thought about his life hanging in the balance. *"Please come back."*

"I-I fell in love with him when I was younger," Izuku whispered.

Tomura stopped inching him forward. He yanked Izuku backwards and forced him to look at him. Tomura's eyes were wild. He stared at Izuku like he crossed a line that even he couldn't save him from.

"You're in *love*?" Tomura hissed.

"Not anymore," Izuku rushed to correct. "I-I—when I was younger I was. An-And I think it has manifested as a mental block."

Izuku expected to be backhanded. He flinched automatically, ready for the pain but nothing came. Instead, Tomura's eyes were full of disbelief and his hands were balled in restraint. His brother furrowed his brow and looked at Izuku up and down.

Tomura's eyes lingered on his battered, ugly arms.

Then Tomura glanced at the window of the woman across the way.

"Does anyone else know this?" Tomura whispered.

"No," Izuku said. "But Himiko knows about the documentation forging we've been doing. I tried to call you but she shot a bullet through my phone. She's planning on telling Nine and having me exterminated."

Tomura's face hardened and his eyes sharpened. Izuku could see plans formulating in Tomura's head. The gears were rapidly churning, but it worried Izuku how calm Tomura was.

"Thank you for telling me," Tomura muttered with a deadly resolve.

Tomura let go of Izuku and pulled out a hunting handgun. It was fully black and made of steel with long-distance bullseye perched at the top. It was exclusively used to hunt animals but only the most skilled of assassins could use it for sniping.

He cocked it and handed it to Izuku.

Tomura placed his hand over Izuku's. He wrapped Izuku's fingers around the cold metal for him and fixed his finger on the trigger. Tomura manhandled Izuku roughly. He positioned Izuku to hold up the gun and aim it at the window.

Izuku looked through the bullseye to see the woman inside. She opened the window to let fresh air in. The wind blew through her beautiful blonde hair and rustled the pearls around her neck.

She closed her eyes to enjoy the feeling of fresh spring on her skin.

"I will fix this," Tomura said from behind Izuku. He leaned over Izuku's shoulder to share his viewpoint. With a delicately gloved hand, Tomura adjusted Izuku's aim by a millimeter. "But first, we need to break your mental block."

The zing of metal echoed into the air. The edge of Tomura's machete pressed into his neck and Izuku froze. It dug into his flesh slightly, drawing out blood. Izuku stilled as his survival instinct swung full force to rattle his bones.

"Take the shot," Tomura commanded.

The terror instilled in him by Tomura triggered his viper .

Izuku hardened with his back against the wall and his brother over his shoulder. He closed his eyes to sink into the bottom of himself. The Viridian Viper slithered awake.

It snaked its way up his back and wrapped around his wrists. But instead of taking the wheel, it burrowed into Izuku's core. It coiled around all his memories of Kacchan. The large viper inside of him towered over the boy with blonde hair and red eyes, poised for the kill.

The viper began squeezing his precious memories tighter and tighter until the memory of the boy snapped in two at the spine.

Izuku pulled the trigger.

The bullet flew swiftly.

It pierced through the memories of the nook. It shattered the memories of the kiss. It snapped the memory of their string wedding bands. It broke every dream Izuku possessed about seeing his Kacchan again and landed into the woman's skull.

Izuku opened his tear filled eyes at the exact moment the bullet lodged in her skull. Her eyes rolled back and her body went limp slowly. Izuku watched as she fell over and in her place, he saw Kacchan with that same bullet hole between his eyes. He saw Hiryu as well.

The three bodies tied together, toppling in sync and hitting the floor in the pool of blood.

Izuku lowered the gun and his arms felt as heavy as lead. He studied the countless blood speckles that decorated the glass and guilt crawled its way up his throat.

Something inside of him broke.

Tomura removed his machete from his throat.

“Let’s get back to Tokyo and clean up this mess,” Tomura muttered. “Don’t say a word about this mental block to *anyone*. I’ll handle this.”

Tomura then whipped out his phone and dialed someone.

“It looks like we’ll need to expedite our plans. Please come to The Academy as soon as possible,” Tomura said to someone’s voicemail.

Izuku couldn’t peel his eyes away from the blood painted window.

For the first time in his life, he felt like he committed a crime.



The Incident

They made it back to Tokyo within a couple of hours.

Tomura’s hand clasped tightly on Izuku’s upper arm. His finger dug into Izuku’s skin, but not enough to be bruised. Izuku let himself be led back to their home, trusting his brother had a plan. But despite trusting Tomura, Izuku couldn’t help but be petrified.

They stepped foot into the lobby and dozens of eyes were on them instantly.

Whispers sparked as all the different vipers looked at them. Izuku wearily glanced at the gathering crowds as they pointed, but Tomura kept his eyes straight forward.

“Keep calm,” Tomura whispered to him. “We need to buy a couple of hours and I can get this all straightened out.”

Immediately, Nine came forward, cutting them off from going further into the building. He was in a polished dark purple suit and on each side of him were six bodyguards poised in all white tactical gear. Standing behind him was Himiko, her arms folded with a frown.

“Seize 217 from 117,” Nine commanded with a chilly air. His eyes were full of death as he pointed to Izuku. “117 no longer has jurisdiction over 217 from this moment on.”

Izuku’s eyes widened.

Tomura’s protective energy spiked. He gritted his teeth, pulled Izuku behind him, and objected to them being torn apart. Several hands began pulling on Izuku and his eyes widened when he saw metal restraints being brought out.

Izuku whimpered when Tomura’s hold grew bruising, but his brother didn’t let go of him. Multiple guards began trying to tear them apart, and Nine’s chilling stare gazed down on them. Izuku was terrified—he began to shake. Tomura clenched his teeth and pulled them tighter together.

“Nine,” Tomura said with a leveled voice. “Hold on for a moment. We can explain our side of things—”

“Shut up,” Nine snapped. He waved his hand for more guards to join in the tussle. “Restrain 117 too.”

A guard tased Tomura directly in the stomach when he refused to let go. Tomura clenched his teeth and knocked the guard back with his elbow through the shocking pain. When he refused to go down, more guards piled on Tomura. It took three more tasers to get Tomura to finally buckle. Tomura’s body jolted in an unnatural way as saliva trickled down his chin.

Izuku gasped in horror when his brother dropped to the ground and cuffs were put on him.

Izuku whirled around trying to get out of the guard’s hold but it was no use. He was overpowered and thrown down on the floor directly across from Tomura. The two brothers stared at each other and Izuku’s eyes were wide with tears while Tomura’s burned with fury.

Izuku was harshly put into restraints with his arms twisted behind his back. The metal dug into his skin as the reality of what was occurring sank into him as well. Tomura might not be able to save him this time.

“I don’t want to die,” Izuku whispered with a sob. “*Please*.”

Tomura’s nostrils flared. His paralyzed body didn’t move as his furious eyes crept over to Nine.

Nine stood over the pair of brothers. His unfeeling eyes locked onto Izuku as he spoke his next words.

“Take 217 to the basement. Permanently.”

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku sat inside of a glass box wearing nothing but a white shirt and loose fitting white cotton pants.

The numbness in his leg slowly but surely went away. Izuku noted this occurred when he stepped foot in the lobby of their home and couldn’t help but find it curious—but there was no use in pondering what that meant now. Was there?

Izuku’s head hung in defeat and his body was beaten into exhaustion. The taste of iron clung to his lips from where the guards roughed him up when they tore him apart from Tomura. His eyes were puffy as he studied his beaten up palm, particularly gazing at the gash that the stranger inflicted on him less than 24 hours ago.

He shifted on the soft cushioning he was sitting on. Inside of the glass box was all white padding. The only light in the room swayed above him. It was a naked bulb that hung from an electrical cord going back and forth like a pendulum. It ticked over him, counting down his last hours.

Izuku heard stories about this box from Himiko.

It was the holding box. It was made of unbreakable tempered glass. It was where dangerous vipers were placed right before they were put down. They would await their fate as the proper punishment for their death was prepared. In front of him were ten guards poised with machine guns all pointed at him in case he attempted anything.

“Didn’t think it would be this soon that you would follow me to the grave,” Hiryu’s ghost murmured from beside him. He sighed and leaned back on his arms. “I thought for sure it would be more like five years.”

Izuku squeezed his eyes closed in an attempt to silence the voice in his head. “Go away.”

“Oh? You’re not going to listen to me now?” Hiryu’s voice chastised.

“You’re not real,” Izuku whispered. He hung his head further down. “You’re just in my head.”

Hiryu’s ghost scoffed. “Oh. I’m more than in your head. You don’t understand what I am yet.”

The door to the chamber opened.

Izuku glanced up from beneath his bangs to see Nine, Ms. Nagant, Mr. Compress enter all at once. Their eyes were sharp on him, and Izuku noted the long, black Katana in Nine’s hands. Behind them were Himiko, Jin, Ibara in a straight line. Izuku felt bitterness swell inside of him at Himiko’s smugness. The gleam in her eyes was similar to as if she won an award.

Izuku was about to frown at her, but stopped himself when Ibara made eye contact with him.

She slowly lifted her pointer finger up to her lips in a ‘shush’ motion.

Izuku furrowed his brow and immediately the hairs on top of his arms stood up.

Nine stood in front of the box with repugnance. He looked at Izuku like he was a failed project as Ms. Nagant pulled out a neat clipboard with several pieces of paper clipped to it.

“I needed to do a deep dive on you and figure out what all was going on,” Nine said with a glare. “117 really did cover for you, didn’t he? I guess he’s slightly defective as well. Seems like he cares about you in an unhealthy manner. But that’s probably my fault for giving you to him so young. Luckily, 215 is easy to crack.”

Izuku hung his head again. His chest pinched at the thought of Aoyama probably being tortured somewhere.

“215 sways so easily when his life is on the line,” Nine said. “Now. Let us get to business.”

Nine snapped his fingers and Ms. Nagant began reading out loud.

“217. Defectiveness level: severe,” Ms. Nagant announced. “Sneaking out. Helping another student during The Cull. Possession of banned books. Possession of banned movies. Knowledge of Obsidian Viper’s defect without informing others.”

Jin gave a low whistle, like he was surprised and impressed.

Ibara didn’t look quite as surprised and she kept her head turned towards the door.

“Conspiracy to potentially allow Obsidian Viper to leave,” Ms. Nagant continued. “Perfect kill streak was broken two years ago and over one hundred marks have been missed since then. Documentation forging for each missed mark while having 117 complete the assignment for him. That completes the list of violations.”

Each strike felt like a hammer upside Izuku’s head.

“We talked to a few others on The Viper Seven team, and evaluated your worth,” Mr. Compress spoke up. “We came to the conclusion that it’s best if you are exterminated.”

“What’s going to happen to Tomura and Aoyama then?” Izuku whispered, finding his voice.

Ms. Nagant sighed and put her hand on her head. She then said, “you’re still far too concerned for others, even when you’re facing the death sentence.”

“If you must know, Tomura will be retrained,” Nine said lightly. “Without you here, I’m sure he can actually reach his full potential. As for Aoyama, he will be stripped of his Viper Seven title immediately. Since he’s not a great fighter he potentially could also be sold elsewhere—”

Nine’s sentence was cut short when the door slammed open behind him.

Everyone’s head whirled at the unexpected intrusion. Izuku’s eyes widened and his heart palpitated at the sight of Tomura. His brother’s features were etched with a bitter subzero cold. He was dressed in his tactical gear and in his hands were both his machetes, cleaned and sharpened.

Tomura’s merciless eyes locked on Nine.

Ibara smirked slightly.

“What’s the meaning of this?” Nine hissed. He turned to the guards and pointed towards Tomura. “Who let him out of his restraints?”

“I did,” a powerful voice boomed.

Everyone stopped, knowing exactly who that was.

Tomura glanced behind him.

Out of the darkness, the body of a golden cane was the first thing to be seen. Next were the diamond eyes of the golden viper head attached onto the cane.

When the figure emerged from the shadows fully, One himself materialized.

His crimson colored eyes were stewed in bloodthirsty malice as his thick curly white hair was combed back. The freckles on his face were in the pattern of blood splatters as they stretched down his neck. He was decorated in a perfectly crisp black suit, gray shirt, and golden tie.

The golden rings on his hands were shined brightly and the ring on his ring finger was a golden Black Mamba that snaked all the way up his appendage.

He walked into the room and stood directly next to Tomura.

Nine's face dropped as did Ms. Nagant's and Mr. Compress'.

The three of them shared a confused set of glances between each other. Izuku didn't miss how worried they looked—as if they didn't know One would be here.

Himiko's eyes widened in confusion. She whipped her head between One, Tomura and Izuku. Then she finally fell back against the wall in the shadows. Jin and Ibara followed suit.

"O-One," Nine said with a stutter. "What are you doing here?"

"I came as soon as Tomura called me," One said. His eyes were homed in on Nine's jugular, not bothering to look him in the eye. "It's been a while since you invited me to check in on The Academy. I know I've been busy with several other things the last few years but I couldn't help but wonder *why*. It seems like things here have been out of hand for a minute now."

Nine cleared his throat and straightened his tie. "Yes, but I am taking care of the defective products now—"

"—That's not what I'm talking about," One snapped. "I'm referring to the fact there hasn't been a new cohort in *years*. You've been lying to me about *my* operations."

Silence.

All eyes were prying into Nine now—staring at him like he slit his own throat.

Lying to Nine was a crime. But lying to One was inconceivable. Even Himiko's face shifted from shock, confusion, then finally she lowered her head. Izuku knew she resigned any hope for Nine at that moment.

One walked over to Nine and stared him down in his eye.

"When were you planning on telling me that Peter Moore cut off all contact with you?" One asked.

Nine couldn't speak. He stumbled on his words for the first time.

"Oh, don't trip up on me *now*," One taunted. "It's a shame you were about to discard a perfectly good viper for lying about what was occurring on assignments when you yourself

have been committing an even bigger lie. Do you really think it's wise to kill Izuku when we have no one to replace him?"

"I'm sorry, Grand Father." Nine immediately kneeled down on the ground in submission. "You're right. I will keep 217 alive. I didn't mean for the lie to go on for so long. I truly did think we would have our affairs sorted out by now. Please. Let me know what I can do to make things right."

"There is nothing you can do," One scoffed. "From here on out, Tomura will be taking over for you."

Everyone's eyes widened. Izuku's head snapped up all the way and he straightened his spine.

Tomura? As the leader of The Academy?

"Oh," Hiryu's ghost whispered. "His long game is *impeccable*."

"Excuse me?" Nine exclaimed. He whipped his head up and glared at Tomura. "He's a *child*. He's barely twenty six—"

"So?" One questioned. His voice boomed on all the walls as he slammed the end of his cane into the ground. "I was slitting throats for Chisaki's grandfather by the time I was ten. Then I was a full fledged assassin for our country by the age of thirteen. By the time I proposed the concept of The Viper Academy to the city of Tokyo I was just sixteen. And I was running it when I was twenty and that's when I found *you* discarded as a baby."

"Yes, I understand all that Grand Father," Nine said. He stood up from his knees and shook his head. "But 117 is not *us*."

"Tomura is *family*," One said with finality. "He's been my informant for years and I've been taking a personal interest in preparing him to be the next King Cobra. After poking around, I found out a lot of the vipers here themselves regard him as the perfect viper. You and I both know *admiration* is more influential than *fear*. The transition to power for him would be easy —"

"No," Nine spat. "I refuse to let this happen. I'm sorry, Grand Father. I respect all decisions you make but not this."

"I had a feeling you might say that," One said unhappily. He folded both of his hands over his cane and tilted his head. "If you think you are so much better than Tomura then prove it to me."

Nine gritted his teeth. "How?"

"Fight him. If you win, then you keep your position. If you fail, you hand him the King Cobra ring and take your punishment in stride."

"I accept," Nine said. He whirled his glare onto Tomura. "I will prove to you that I am far more suitable for the role than 117—"

“—Tomura,” One corrected.

Nine’s eyebrow twitched. “…I am far more suitable for the role than *Tomura* ever would be.”

“Tomura,” One called. “Do you accept the challenge?”

All eyes were on Tomura now.

Tomura’s face didn’t shift during this conversation. The whole time his eyes were trained on Izuku. With patience, Tomura walked over to the glass box Izuku was in. Izuku looked up as Tomura neared. There was a veil over Tomura’s eyes as he studied Izuku’s new cuts and scrapes.

Tomura’s chest heaved slightly, angry about something.

“I accept,” Tomura said with a slight growl.

Tomura raked his machetes against each other. He turned around gradually, eyes piercing through Nine. Nine’s expression hardened and his stature changed to going on the offense.

“Let’s make this quick,” Nine hissed.

“Take your stances,” One commanded.

Darkness fell over the room as everyone moved to the sides, opening up the floor to the two men.

Izuku pressed his hand against the glass of his box as he watched. His skin was covered in goosebumps, unsure of where this was going to go.

All eyes were honed in as the winds of change swept through. The two vipers encircled each other, and it was then Izuku could plainly see the irony in this face off.

Tomura and Nine shared physical traits that made their rivalry eerie. Same shade of white hair. The same tall, threatening build and height. The color of their eyes was even almost similar—set off ever so slightly with Tomura’s being alizarin while Nine’s was an imperial purple.

It was like Tomura was Nine’s dark mirror staring back at him as the better, newer, upgraded version of himself.

Nine began to undress, preparing himself for the battle. He got rid of his tie and shrugged off the blazer. He took his shirt off slowly to expose his scarred chest. It was full of cuts and scrapes from a life before either Izuku or Tomura was born.

He was well defined in a way that displayed a lifetime of training. Izuku could probably guess the lives taken by his hands were infinite. Nine gripped the hilt of his black katana and unsheathed it. The blade shined under the dim light. He dragged it against the concrete as he walked into the middle of the floor with his eyes trained on Tomura.

Tomura smirked in an insidious manner. He cracked his knuckles like Nine fell right into the center of his plans.

Slowly, Tomura moved to do the same as Nine and removed his shirt. It was then Izuku finally saw the full breadth of his brother's viper tattoos. They covered his chest, abdomen and sides in intertwining tangles.

At the center of his back was a new tattoo. It was a large horned viper in the shape of an infinity symbol, eating its own tail. Ouroboros, Izuku thought to himself. The symbol for immortality.

Above the viper was the Japanese character for life and at the bottom was the character for death.

Tomura cracked his neck as he gripped both his machetes and stood across from Nine.

"Begin," One commanded.

Straight away, both Nine and Tomura moved for the kill. Their clashing metal reverberated the room as they collided in a fury of slashes and blows.

Nine was faster than any assassin Izuku ever saw. The years of experience he held over Tomura was evident. He was keen in his dodges, moving his body simple millimeters to evade deadly blows. Then wherever Tomura left an opening, Nine was skilled enough to immediately stab for it. He cut Tomura behind the shins in order to slow his movements.

If this was any other opponent, this would have worked.

However, Tomura was crafted from sheer endurance. He soaked up the pain like it made him stronger. Tomura moved as if he didn't feel pain, and Izuku questioned if he did.

Tomura quickly changed his fighting style to defensive. Tomura dodged blow after blow, studying Nine's posture with every step. He assessed which way Nine's weight leaned. He sized up how far his reach was with the sword and he noted the side he was slower at defending.

Nine seemingly saw this, and changed his fighting style to avoid being bested—but it was too late. Tomura made his calculations.

Within the next second Tomura executed a perfect combo of blows that went for all of Nine's weak points. He swung for Nine's jugular and right as expected, Nine leaned backwards out of the way. Tomura faked him out and switched his footing quickly. He then swung his second machete.

He cut Nine deeply in the oblique and dragged it to rip his flesh clean.

Blood sprayed and Nine immediately tried to go full defensive.

Tomura didn't let up as he forced Nine backwards. Slash after slash rained down in a brutal rhythm. For every blow Nine was able to dodge, Tomura forced two more on him. Gashes

were carved into Nine's arms, legs, and chest in mere minutes. With every blow Tomura's eyes became more and more satiated at the pain.

All the vipers in the room gasped when Nine began to stagger, showing weakness.

Tomura's bloodthirsty eyes caught the mistake and he pounced immediately. One. Two. Three slices were given to Nine's weak points. Nine yelled in agony as the blade cut straight through the tendons in both his heels. Then finally Tomura swiftly kicked him off his feet and body slammed him into the concrete floor.

Ibara smiled at the sound of Nine's skull cracking.

Tomura put his foot on Nine's chest and pushed one of his machetes to rest at the jugular of Nine's neck. The vein pulsed against the steel as Nine roughly breathed in and out.

Defeat sagged Nine's shoulders—he'd been bested.

"Fine," Nine said through his gritted teeth. He gripped his bleeding side as he glared at One. "I give my position to Tomura. But heed my word, you'll regret this later, One." Nine angrily pushed away the machete. He staggered upright, resting on his knees as he tried his best to clutch his side.

Tomura circled behind him, looming without a word.

It was then that Tomura glanced over at One.

One gave a single head nod.

Tomura's eyes burrowed to a level of darkness they never achieved before. All the fury of resentment and thirst for power melted together as he reeled back his blade. He viciously barred his teeth as he swung the machete.

Nine noticed too late. He quickly turned to see what was happening behind him but the blade ferociously swept through.

Several people in the room gasped, Izuku included.

The machete severed Nine's head from his neck in a fell, savage swoop. Everyone but One himself stared on in shock as it happened. The blood from Nine's arteries sprayed upwards, raining down dark crimson directly on Tomura.

An unsettling smile twitched onto Tomura's blood soaked face. Nausea rocked into Izuku's stomach at the unnerving nature of it. Izuku glanced around and was even more terrified to witness how everyone stared on in awe like they were witnessing Tomura being born again in Nine's blood.

One began grinning as the red liquid turned Tomura's hair from pure white to red.

Izuku slowly backed away from the edge of his cage as Tomura kicked over the decapitated body. Nine's head rolled across the room, leaving a trail of blood until it stopped directly at

One's shoe.

One lifted his clean boot up, and pressed it directly on Nine's disembodied face.

"Bravo," One said. He slowly clapped with delight. "Thank you for taking care of that liar for me, Tomura."

Tomura bowed his head. "It's my honor."

"Like we agreed, go ahead and claim your prize."

Tomura leaned down and lifted up Nine's limp, lifeless hand.

He tried to keep his face expressionless, but the emotion of unequivocal victory was teeming from out of all of his pores. Prudently, Tomura plucked the silver King Cobra shaped ring off of Nine's dead flesh. Tomura held it up to the light for a moment, admiring it. It shone in the light, sparkling as blood dripped off of it onto the ground.

Then Tomura slowly placed it on himself like it was a crowning. He flexed his muscular hand, testing the new power that came with the ring as the strength surged through his veins.

Tomura's nostrils flared as he breathed in.

He breathed out with a sinister grin.

Izuku was frozen in place.

One rolled his shoulders. "Everyone, we're going to have an all hands meeting after this. It's time to get things in order around here for good."

Mr. Compress and Ms. Nagant nodded. They seemed unfazed by the turn over of power. All the guards followed One loyally and no one bothered to spare a glance at Nine's maimed body. Izuku knew they held no empathy in their hearts. Ultimately they would follow whatever command One gave—and now Tomura.

"What story should we tell people if they ask what happened to Nine?" Ms. Nagant questioned. "Surely we're not going to let it be known he lied to you about the cohort issue successfully for this long."

One rolled Nine's head underneath his shoe thoughtfully. He then said, "I think I will tell people he died in a freak accident. An *incident*—if you will. Now. Let us get to business about securing the next cohort. Tomura proposed a new way to obtain children."

One kicked Nine's head off to the side.

He snapped his fingers and pointed towards the dead body. Within seconds, the guards began gathering up Nine's remains. Not a single soul spoke as their once ruler was carried off in two pieces.

Slowly everyone trickled out of the chamber, forgetting about Izuku. Jin. Ibara.

Himiko spared him one glance and then it was only Izuku and Tomura left alone with a pool of blood. Tomura stood over the red liquid, looking at his reflection. He tilted his head side to side, and gazed on at the ring that now sat at home on his finger.

Tomura's eyes snaked over to Izuku.

He walked to the glass wall that separated them wearing a thoughtful expression. His lips were thinly pressed together as his eyes glanced up and down Izuku's arms.

Tomura held his blood covered hand up to the glass and Izuku slowly stood up.

Izuku's vision pulsed white from the exhaustion as he walked to the front of his cage. The spots in his eyes danced as his legs screamed in protest with every step. Izuku looked at his brother's bloodied hand. He then put his hand up against the glass as well.

They stood in silence.

Izuku waited patiently for the next move. His heart hit against his chest over and over like a drum, expecting to be let out.

However, nothing happened.

Tomura looked at the lock. So did Izuku.

Tomura slowly removed his hand, leaving a crimson handprint behind. Izuku frowned, and he swayed on his weak legs when anxiety crept into him.

"Tomura?" Izuku cautiously called.

Then, Tomura backed away from the glass. Izuku's vision faded further into white from all his energy being depleted. Izuku breathed unevenly as he leaned against the glass for support. He wearily stared into his brother's eyes that were endless pools of nothing.

Panic stacked high in Izuku as Tomura took another step backwards.

"To-Tomura?" Izuku questioned again.

When Tomura took another step, Izuku's gut felt like it'd been sucker punched.

"He doesn't need you anymore," Hiryu's phantom tried to tell him. "All you were good for was making him look like a perfect Big Brother. You helped him get the high rank and respect. Now, he got what he wanted. He made himself look like the perfect viper until he could seize control for himself."

Izuku's heart rate quickened. "Tomura, please no—don't leave me here."

Tomura turned his back, leaving Izuku to gaze at the blood soaked Ouroboros tattoo that stretched across his skin.

“Tomura!” Izuku screamed. He banged louder and louder on the glass with every growing second. “Tomura! No! Don’t—Don’t le-leave me! Don’t leave me here! *Please*!”

Tomura glanced once over his shoulder at Izuku. He basked in blood and his newly acquired power as he reached for the light switch.

“Tomura!”

Darkness consumed the room and the door slammed shut.



Four Days After The Incident

The blackness faded into countless hours of mental torture as Izuku’s body began to shut down.

His system was in overdrive and far past the point of survival mode. He was clinging to life as he laid there neglected, dreaming of better days. The basement was a bitter type of cold that wasn’t cold enough to freeze but enough to cause him to convulse into violent shivers.

The padding where he was wet with tears. Izuku couldn’t control the sobs that he poured into the dingy material. His stomach felt like it was trying to devour itself from the inside out. It hurt to blink, cough, or breathe.

He’d been starved of any food or water and was left alone with his cruel thoughts.

“I told you, he doesn’t need you anymore,” Hiryu whispered in his head. “He only kept you around to look good in front of Nine. Now he doesn’t need you. You’re disposable.”

“He’s going to leave you down here to die, runt,” The ghost of Sen said. The dead boy joined Hiryu in the dark corner of Izuku’s mind with a viciously, delightedly smirk. “He’s never coming back for you.”

Izuku weakly curled into himself more.

His head was becoming light.

“At least you can come home with me now,” a new, soft voice said.

The sound of The Dance of The Lovebirds came in gently.

Izuku lifted his head weakly at the strange new voice. When he thought he opened his eyes, he swore he saw a tiny figure there, standing behind Hiryu and Sen. The small frame was haloed by a yellowish light and looking at him with a gentleness he never knew.

“I’ll always be here for you,” Kacchan’s voice said. “We can finally run away together.”

More tears swelled in Izuku’s eyes as he stared. The small figure became brighter—showing the boy from his past in full clarity now.

Izuku could perfectly see the beautiful red eyes and blond hair he was stuck on. It felt nearly real and Izuku knew now why he didn't want to die. He needed to see that boy one last time before he started a new lifetime.

He looked at the boy he wished he ran away with sadly.

"C'mon," Kacchan beckoned. He extended his arm and stretched out his palm for Izuku. "Take my hand and we can go."

A tear rolled down Izuku's cheek.

With his final bit of strength he lifted his hand and tried to grasp the last red strand in his life. When he thought he touched the smaller hand—a larger one eclipsed around his wrist. The warm scarlet eyes Izuku dreamed about were replaced with deadly, frigid ones.

Slowly, the mirage faded away and in place stood the very real, malevolent Tomura.

His brother stared down at him like he was a precious emerald.

Izuku tried to pull his hand back—but Tomura gripped him tightly.

Tomura bent down to lift Izuku upright and the whole room swayed. Famine protested around Izuku's muscles and his vision spotted black. Izuku blinked rapidly as his heart struggled to pump blood.

"No dying on me yet, Izuku," Tomura said. "I still need you."

Izuku tried to stay awake—but the darkness pulled him under.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When Izuku gained consciousness again, it was to an overwhelming light. Everything around him blended in blurry colors of gray, black, and beige. His vision pulled into focus to show him the inside of an expensive penthouse he'd never been in before.

Izuku's head swayed backwards with confusion and he tried to orient his weak body.

He registered that he was standing up. No. Not standing—leaning. He was leaning against something? Someone. It was a warm body. His finger felt out the body and he registered it was a man. Izuku's eyes struggled in and out of focus until finally he could see Tomura.

But everything about Tomura looked different.

Instead of his casual tech gear, his brother was wearing a suit similar to Nine's. It was black, crisp and ironed to perfection. The blazer was made of an expensive material and his tie was a sharp silver. His hands were now fully decorated with single rings.

Sitting on his index finger was the silver King Cobra ring, shined and rid of blood.

Tomura looked like a leader now.

“Ah, you’re finally awake,” Tomura said with a slanted smirk.

Izuku wanted to speak but the dryness in his throat was choking him. He groaned when his head pulsed with radiating pain. His head lobbed again and suddenly Izuku was aware of Tomura hoisting him up by the waist.

“Welcome to our new home,” Tomura announced happily. “This is Nine’s old penthouse. Now it’s ours.”

Tomura maneuvered Izuku’s head for him so he could see.

All around were tall gray walls, dark marble, and black silk curtains. The decor was dark yet luxe and there were silver statues of life sized vipers in various corners. Off to the side was an inside waterfall along with a lit fireplace and a spiral staircase that went three levels up.

Izuku became dizzy and he gripped onto Tomura tighter.

They began walking around as Izuku looked at the incredibly high ceiling. Dangling above them was a delicate crystal chandelier that illuminated the whole space. They stumbled into what Izuku presumed to be the lavish living room. Tomura delicately placed him down like a doll on a plush black sectional couch by the fireplace.

Izuku shivered, still trying his best to stay conscious.

“We’ll get you some food soon,” Tomura reassured. “I gave you a punishment of famine for what you told me about that boy with red eyes and blond hair. But now all that’s behind us.”

The pain in Izuku’s stomach felt acidic now. He weakly moaned, unable to formulate any words or thoughts.

Tomura stood up and his eyes raked over Izuku’s body.

Izuku noticed that the binder of men Tomura gifted him was on the wooden coffee table in front of him. He blinked slowly at it. His eyes lingered closed, and he nearly welcomed the darkness once more.

When he opened his eyes again, Tomura was standing in front of the roaring fireplace with the binder.

His brother then opened the binder and one by one, tore out the sheets to allow the fire to eat the paper.

“I remember the first day they handed me to you,” Tomura said. His eyes stayed glued on the fire. “I was seven, it was a blazing summer and I just spent six days in the basement with a famine punishment too. Everyone else in my cohort had Big Brothers and Sisters to take care of them but I didn’t. Nine miscalculated the *imports*. He told me I was an extra.”

The crackling from the charred paper echoed into the quiet penthouse with Izuku’s uneven breathing.

“No one gave a damn about me—but then you came along,” Tomura muttered. He threw another profile into the fire. “Who would have thought the first person to think I was important would be some sniveling two year old? You were crying for your mom and confused. I should have found it disgusting—but I didn’t. Your hair was a mess so I pushed it out the way.”

Tomura looked at the picture of one of the blond men from the binder before chucking it away into the flames.

“I felt something then for you that never went away,” Tomura confessed. “I felt *sad*, but more importantly I felt related to you by pain not blood.”

Izuku’s brows furrowed as he intently listened from the couch.

“You stopped crying when you saw me and for the first time someone looked at me like I was *important*. I told you I was your new brother. You held your arms out and I picked you up and you clung to me. I realized then as you were shaking in my arms that you *noticed* me. You told me you were scared and I was too. We both were. But something pulled inside me and I stopped being scared for the both of us.”

Tomura finished emptying the binder and then tossed it in the fire too. A large crackle boomed from the fireplace as it swallowed up the material. Tomura turned around again, and began to pull his long hair back into a neat bun with a red string.

“Now, we don’t have to be afraid of anyone else anymore,” Tomura said finally.

He walked over to Izuku and shifted him upright.

“Shirt off,” Tomura commanded coldly.

Of course, Izuku thought. Famine wasn’t enough. Especially not after Izuku confessed to being in love with someone when he was younger.

Izuku blinked rapidly. He lifted a wobbly hand to take his shirt off, unclasping the first button with his dirty fingers. He began to sloppily sink to the floor. His muscles automatically poised in position for brute punishment only to be stopped.

Tomura grabbed him by the arm and forced him back up on the couch.

“No. No more punishments like that,” Tomura corrected.

Izuku halted.

He lifted his heavy head. He was unsure if he heard that correctly.

“…No more?” Izuku wheezed out.

“No more belt punishments,” Tomura repeated. He then took Izuku’s shirt off for him. “I won’t be hitting you ever again. With Nine gone, I realize what I was doing was, ah, *extreme*.” Tomura handled Izuku like he was suddenly valuable. “Now that I’m in charge, I’m

going to be approaching everything differently. Including how we execute your punishments."

Tomura discarded Izuku's shirt to the side and then carefully inspected his wounds. His fingers grazed all the cuts, scrapes and bruises. He focused on the red welts and inspected Izuku closely.

It was then Tomura stood up, went to the bathroom area and returned with a basket of expensive ointments. He pulled out several creams with fancy labels that still had the high dollar sign price tag attached to them.

Izuku was confused at first but then Tomura held one up for him to see.

"As an apology, let me help you clear your skin from those ugly marks," Tomura said with a tight lipped smile. "It'll be like erasing all those years."

Mixed emotions fought for dominance inside of Izuku's ribcage.

Anger was the first to spark. He was furious that Tomura thought all that could simply be washed away. Even if the marks left—the fear inflicted would stay. But soon, rising like a tide inside of Izuku was the emotion of *relief*.

Izuku nodded the best he could in his state, hoping this was real.

He stared at the new version of his brother as Tomura started coating his scars with the expensive skincare items. Tomura looked refined. Well put together. He looked as if he conquered a beast he'd been wanting to slay for years. He kneaded his fingers against Izuku's skin and made Izuku relax on the comfortable couch.

When Tomura finished coating his skin in the various creams and lotions, his brother walked into the kitchen.

Izuku noticed now that even Tomura's walk was different. Every step he took felt like an omnipotent stride. More so than Nine ever walked.

Tomura's new air was chillingly dominant.

When Tomura returned from the kitchen, he was holding a large silver platter full of Izuku's favorite foods.

Izuku perked up. Tomura smiled and placed it down right in front of him. Izuku reached for the chopsticks and Tomura turned on the large TV mounted above the fireplace.

As the news played, Izuku struggled to feed himself. He attempted to grip the utensils several times and failed. When it became a bit embarrassing, Tomura spared him. His brother grasped the chopsticks and then slowly began to feed him. Izuku shifted uncomfortably at the action but allowed himself to be helped in his weakened state.

Tomura stayed silent, fully invested in watching Izuku get nursed back to health.

Suddenly, right before Izuku could swallow his first bite, the sound of a crying baby bounced off the walls.

Izuku furrowed his brow and tilted his head up to the third level of the penthouse. Dread hugged him like an old friend when the crying steadily grew louder. Izuku knew there was only *one* explanation.

He inched his gaze to Tomura, who was radiating a glacial aura.

“Oh, I forgot to mention,” Tomura said as he picked up another bite for Izuku to eat. “That’s your new little brother. His name is Katsuma.”

Chapter End Notes

Thank you guys so much for reading!! Lemme know your thoughts below :3 Excited for the next two chapters! It timeskips into the present. We'll get to see Izuku's POV of Paradise and the Honeymoon phase. We will also be further unraveling what happened while they were in Biei that Katsuki didn't see! Thank you so much for reading!!! I look forward to all your screams :3

Chapter 22: Attacco

Chapter Summary

Attacco (It.) — binding together two notes.
The name comes from the Italian attaccare, "to unite"

Chapter Notes

Helloooo! Welcome back to this lovely train wreck, I mean love boat :) First, thank you to Luna for betaing like always!

Secondly, thank you all for reading this far! We've finally seeing the light at the end of the tunnel and circling up on catching up on the present. Almost all my little dominos are in place and I'm so stoke for these upcoming chapters!

It'll be a lot of fluff! After the Paradise Recap, it'll be more bkdk fluffy and smutty scenes from the Honey Moon arc that weren't in Katsuki's POV. I've tortured you all enough with angst so here's tooth rotting fluff as a thank you for sticking around :')

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 22 - Attacco

.

.

.

Izuku was always a believer in fate.

Fate decided the future, past and present. Fate was the reason he was banished to the Viper Academy when his mother decided his freckles were a curse. Fate was something no one could outrun, even if they wanted to. Everything was predetermined.

But Izuku hesitated if he thought fate was immovable when Tomura placed a tiny bundle in his arms.

The soft blanket wrapped around the infant was orange. Izuku knew he would never forget that detail. A gentle, delicate orange. In his stomach, anxiety burrowed into him like a cluster of worms.

Katsuma.

Izuku's whole childhood flashed before his eyes.

"Exactly five kids have joined us," Tomura informed him. "Katsuma, Tamashiro, Eri, Hana and Kota. One for everyone, besides me, in our unit. I told One a smaller cohort is more effective because we can concentrate our efforts better."

They were standing on the third floor of their new penthouse. Up here was a rooftop balcony. It led out to the perfect view of Mt. Fuji and the entire vast city of Tokyo. There were three rooms: one entertainment room, one private study, and lastly, one nursery for their new brother.

The baby roused in his arms. Izuku instinctively drew him closer to his chest. The baby snuggled into him and Izuku's heart skipped a beat.

"How is this possible?" Izuku whispered. "I thought Peter Moore cut off contact with Nine?"

"He did," Tomura said. He stood next to Izuku studying Katsuma as well. "But I proposed a whole new Viper Academy system to One before the incident. It included upgraded training plans and a new avenue of getting the next cohort."

Izuku grew sad knowing Katsuma was sold.

"You found a new trafficker?" Izuku asked.

"No," Tomura said. "I proposed to One we should kidnap a small number of infants from various hospitals."

Izuku's heart stopped.

ᔓᔓᔓ

5 Year After The Incident

Izuku softly played the violin in Katsuma's bedroom. The music carried throughout the penthouse like fluttering butterflies. The wings of each note soared high and dipped low. Izuku smiled as Katsuma gradually drifted off to sleep in his bed, snuggled up with a small All Might toy.

Izuku gradually trailed off the note he was on. He carefully waited until Katsuma was fast asleep before stopping fully. He studied his little brother with contemplation. His heart squeezed at the faint, tiny sprinkle of freckles across the bridge of Katsuma's nose.

"Did he have trouble getting to sleep again?" Aoyama quietly asked from the doorway.

"Yeah," Izuku muttered. He slowly put his instrument away. "I think I might've accidentally gotten him used to me playing violin before bed. I guess he was listening to me play all these years."

“How sweet,” Aoyama said with a small smile.

“I guess.” Izuku laughed and scratched the back of his head. “Thank you again for watching him while we go out tonight on client business.”

“It’s not a problem at all,” Aoyama said with a smile. “It’s kinda nice being the designated night babysitter of the unit! I can work while watching the baby monitors.”

Izuku chuckled at his brother. They walked out of the nursery and Aoyama stole a handful of glances at him. Then he cleared his throat.

“Have you…seen Himiko at all?” Aoyama asked carefully.

Izuku’s smile dropped.

“No,” Izuku said curtly. “You know she doesn’t talk to me. She avoids me like the plague.”

“Yeah but I was hoping she would come around soon,” Aoyama muttered. “After her demotion she only takes months-long overseas assignments now. She’s barely around to help out with her Little.”

“She probably wants to keep out of Tomura’s way,” Izuku said with a shrug.

He tried to tell himself not to be bitter, but it was hard.

After Nine’s beheading, Tomura wanted Himiko to be next. She’d proven her loyalties were not in the correct place like Ibara’s and Jin’s. If One hadn’t been there, Himiko surely would have been in the grave. But One was, and One told Tomura it wasn’t entirely her fault. She was pledging loyalty to the leader of the house—which was not a bad trait to have.

She escaped Tomura’s wrath by a hair. She was allowed to keep her life but not Tomura’s respect. She was given lower ranked missions, and was barely called upon unless it was specific Viper Seven business.

Because of this, Himiko kept her head down these days.

“Well, if you happen to run into her at all tell her I’m looking for her,” Aoyama said sadly. “Her Little misses her and I can only do so much to really take care of two kids.”

“Sure thing,” Izuku replied.

Aoyama huffed and nervously chuckled. “Well. Enough about that—you should get going. You wouldn’t want to keep Tomura waiting.”

Izuku nodded, feeling awkward about the way their conversation ended.

“Right. Thanks again, Aoyama.”

The two said their goodbyes as Izuku descended to the second floor of the penthouse.

The second level held his and Tomura's bedrooms alongside a large den. There was a small indoor garden next to the windows where Izuku tended to a group of plants. The tiny flowers brought him a level of peace. It was nice to see something grow instead of die.

He walked into his room. It was still decorated with all the same vintage romance posters.

On his bed awaiting him was the outfit Tomura chose. It was a simple sleeveless black shirt with a high collar. The fabric hugged his waist, chest, and back, leaving little to the imagination. To emphasize it more his black pants were tight enough to show all his muscles.

Izuku looked in the full length mirror. He assessed his clear skin.

Over the last five years, Tomura kept his word and never hit Izuku again. Instead, Izuku's punishments involved the glass box in the basement. It was a betrayal in Izuku's opinion. Tomura spent years telling him he would spare him from the basement. He would rub in how *lucky* Izuku was to never have to go down there.

Then he banished Izuku to the basement the exact moment Nine was gone.

It made Izuku realize Tomura never cared about sparing him from the basement. Tomura only cared about wanting to be the one to inflict the pain—and pain he did inflict.

The several days of famine always wore Izuku down.

And each time, a bit of Izuku's trust in Tomura chipped away.

But despite all this—Tomura made sure to never touch him unless it involved helping clear up his scars. The fancy skincare regimen Tomura placed him on worked like a magic wand erasing the marks.

But some scars stayed, like the one on his palm he received from his stranger. However, that was to be expected. They couldn't heal all the years of violence. But the faintness of Izuku's scars were like an air of mystery now rather than a cloak of shame.

Izuku traced the scar on his palm thoughtfully. He did this frequently because the kindness the stranger showed him that day was rare. Whenever he was feeling sad, he thought about how quick his stranger was to help him escape the city. Even though he hadn't managed to get away.

When Izuku descended down the spiral staircase, his happiness slipped away fully.

Leaving Katsuma behind always made Izuku sad.

Over the last five years Izuku could feel himself change. He shifted into a Big Brother and he thought about Katsuma a lot. He thought about his food. His hair. His clothing and what made him smile.

But more so, he thought about Katsuma's real family. Unlike the previous cohorts, these kids weren't blood money. These kids parents' were probably *searching* for them.

Their fate wasn't to be locked up in this hell hole.

Izuku's heart clenched every time he stared at Katsuma's happy face.

Tomura's new Viper Academy system was effective and One gave him high praise for it. Truly, it was simple. When it was said out loud, Izuku wondered why it hadn't been thought of before.

Tomura proposed that Littles should strictly be for the higher ranked Vipers of the previous cohort when they became adults. The Viper Seven would be the first trial of this. Himiko received Tamashiro. Ibara took in Eri. Aoyama was in charge of Hana. And lastly, Jin was given Kota. He was overjoyed for a second chance at being a Big Brother.

The family dinners now included the five kids. The children played together in a way that sustained them with proper attention. All the while they were molded in the Viper way. It was working. Izuku could see the viciousness coming out of Kota similar to Sen.

However, Katsuma was a mirror of Izuku: soft and meek.

Because of that, Izuku couldn't silence the loud buzzing in his skull. Whenever he stared at the kids, he saw Nine's death over and over.

Watching Nine get beheaded the same week he was handed a newborn made it abruptly clear how horrifying this all was. It was an endless cycle of death and Izuku didn't want to guess which of the kids would die before the age of ten.

But he didn't have much say in the matter.

Tomura was in charge of not only their unit—but all operations. As the new manager of the Viper Academy, Tomura ruled with an iron machete. He doubled the amount of missions in less than two years and he made valuable connections to new clients overseas. Nine was nothing but an example of what happened when you crossed One and pissed off Tomura.

More so, Tomura ran The Academy better than Nine ever did. Every Viper dutifully admired him. They all aspired to be as ruthless, calculating and violent as he was.

That is, everyone except Izuku.

The broken trust Izuku gained in Tomura after The Incident made Izuku internally resistant.

He didn't want to be like Tomura. And Izuku didn't want Katsuma to be like him either.

Izuku exhaled at the bitter thoughts about his brother.

It's exactly who he was going to meet now. Tomura requested he come out for dinner with him in the third circle of Hadeus.

He walked out of their home into the streets of Tokyo. He started heading straight for the entrance he usually used to get to the underground city. Along the way, several whistles called out to him.

“Hey there, *Izuku*,” a woman said with a sing-song tone.

Izuku chuckled nervously as he waved to her.

He kept walking and various men and women attempted to grab his attention. They promised him a good time with flirty gazes. Izuku blushed as he sweetly smiled at each person that cat-called him. He gave the familiar people of Hadeus a polite head nod in an attempt not to be rude.

A particular gruff man with an eye patch whistled at him. He curled his finger in a ‘come here’ motion at Izuku.

Izuku knew this guy was a pusher. He had been trying to fuck him for three years and was extremely persistent. Izuku rejected the offer yet again and walked slightly faster.

“Aw, c’mon baby boy,” the man yelled after him. “I know you’re shy but I could make you cum so hard you see *stars*!”

“Sorry!” Izuku called back with a smile. “Still not interested!”

Heat burned at the back of Izuku’s neck. When he turned the corner, he puffed out his cheeks in an attempt to cool down.

Izuku didn’t know if he could ever get used to that.

The last five years changed for Izuku more than just internally, they changed him externally too. He was always regarded as attractive, sure. He knew that. But over the last several years, his looks began to turn heads wherever he went without fail. Jin said he was one of those people who only got finer with age.

Because of this, Izuku was no longer strictly The Viper Academy’s gem, but Hadeus’ as well.

It started when his skin began to heal.

When his arms became acceptable, Tomura asked Ibara to give Izuku a makeover. His brother was very insistent that he wanted Izuku to be the most stunning person in the room at all times. This was because Tomura wanted to establish their influence in the underground—and beauty was influential.

Ibara delivered happily. She treated Izuku like a doll she played dress up with. Izuku enjoyed it. He was happy to spend quality time with his sister. Ibara kept all his outfits sweet but slightly sexy. They were alluring but not so much that they screamed ‘look at me’.

And it worked like a charm.

All eyes were always on Izuku—and all hands wanted to touch.

But Tomura didn’t let anyone.

He dangled Izuku in front of clients as a way to gain attention. It was successful. Many people kissed Tomura's ring for the prospect of getting closer to Izuku. But they never did. Izuku was entirely disinterested in anyone in Hadeus, and even if he was, Izuku was sure Tomura would rather gut a person than let anything happen.

Tomura was ferociously protective of Izuku's body, like he was guarding it.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku reached the usual underground entrance of Hadeus that was exclusive to Vipers.

He swiped his watch and the blue lights lit up. He rode the elevator down the steep drop patiently. When he reached his destination on the first circle, Izuku began his descent. He walked quickly while also saying hello to people he knew.

When he finally reached the third circle, Izuku looked around for the restaurant.

His brother wanted him there to help *ease* a business deal with a Thai client. That usually meant he wanted Izuku to look pretty in the background while playing the violin. It helped add an air of sophistication to the mix while Tomura negotiated.

Izuku re-read the text Tomura sent him. He was to meet in the number six private lounge. Izuku walked along the endless string of rooms. Each one had long, velvet green curtains with golden numbers above. Izuku found the golden six and stopped in front of it.

There were two bodyguards placed out front. They patted Izuku down then stepped aside.

Izuku pulled the curtains back, walked into the private lounge, then froze.

All around were Yakuza members, distinguishable by their tattoos and threatening stares. They were on the couch. Against the wall. Behind the private bar and the two tables. Some were standing by the piano that was off to the side of the room laughing as they pressed some of the keys.

Standing in the middle of the dim room was Chisaki.

A haze of fog encompassed him from all the cigar smoke. He was tall and intimidating like he always was as he held a cup of whiskey in his hands. Chisaki was dressed in an all black pinstripe suit and a long, expensive jacket with black fur on the collar hanging off his shoulders like a cape.

His piercing gold eyes cut through all the smog and landed on Izuku.

"Oh, I'm sorry for intruding, Mr. Chisaki," Izuku quickly spluttered. He bowed deeply and began to walk right back out. "I must've gotten the rooms mixed up—"

"—You're in the right one," Chisaki corrected.

Izuku stopped.

He eyed Chisaki. The powerful man smiled at him in a way that was reserved for people who were informal with each other.

“Sorry for the ambush,” Chisaki said while tilting his head. “Your brother is running a bit late. He canceled the other business meeting for one with me. I hope you don’t mind.”

Izuku hesitated slightly. He did mind—but he could never voice that considering Chisaki was the most powerful man in Japan.

“Of course not,” Izuku quickly said. “Always a pleasure to see you, Mr. Chisaki.”

Chisaki curiously studied Izuku’s bare arms.

Then slowly the room bled back into normal conversations. Izuku breathed out to steady himself. It’s not that he didn’t like the Yakuza—he just didn’t feel comfortable around people who could collect his head and have no consequences for it. Tomura was one of the most powerful people in Hadeus now, sure, but he was not as powerful as the Yakuza Heir.

Izuku glanced around and next to the piano was a black violin.

It was perched beside an intricately designed music stand. Izuku knew that was his station and took his place. He carefully tuned the violin and looked at the music sheet Tomura picked out for him to play.

He sat down in the music chair and glanced at the door.

Where is Tomura? Izuku thought.

Suddenly, a burly man walked up to Izuku. He was wearing all purple and a crooked smile. The smell of Hennessy was laced in his breath.

“Wow. You’re more stunning in person,” the Yakuza member said, swaying slightly. He leaned down into Izuku’s space a little too close for comfort. “The rumors *really* don’t do you justice.”

“Thank you,” Izuku replied with an affable smile.

Without being prompted, the drunken man’s hand shot out. He went for Izuku’s hair, entranced by the shiny curls.

Izuku quickly caught the man’s wrist and twisted it backwards. Izuku’s face didn’t change when the man hissed out loud in pain. His yell drew attention from everyone in the room. Izuku kept twisting with the brute strength people always forgot he possessed.

As the man screamed for Izuku to let go, Izuku stared coldly at him.

Being touched without his permission was Izuku’s biggest pet peeve. These days, any unwanted touch bitterly reminded him that he was property. People seemed to forget that while he was attractive he was not an *attraction* they could freely paw at.

An amused smirk stretched across Chisaki's lips.

"Careful," Tomura's voice suddenly cut in. "I've cut off men's hands for that."

Everyone turned to see Tomura entering the room.

The scars on his face grew with him, maturing his features into cracked porcelain. His hair was pure white now with a slight tinge of blue. The long hair was pulled back into a half up and down bun with a red string. And in his eyes was a ruthlessness that refined over the last five years.

If looks could kill, a single glance from Tomura could slit a thousand throats.

In his hands were three thick, silver chain leashes. At the end of each one was an all black Doberman. Tomura's guard dogs: Clotho, Lachesis, and Atropos. The same as Izuku, Tomura was also a believer in fate. He believed he was destined to be the ruler of the Tokyo underground. As an homage he bought three all black dogs to mimic Hades' Cerberus.

Izuku let go of the man's wrist to bow at Tomura's arrival—as did the rest of the room.

Even Chisaki gave a half shallow bow.

The drunken man staggered off to the corner nursing his wrist. Chisaki opened his arms and welcomed Tomura with an amiable smirk.

"So glad you could fit me in," Chisaki said as Tomura approached him.

"My pleasure," Tomura said. "I'm happy you returned my calls. Now, shall we get to business?"

"Lets."

With his hand that was holding the glass of whiskey, Chisaki gestured for Tomura to join him on the leather couch. The couch was facing directly towards the piano and where Izuku was stationed. Tomura glanced one time at Izuku with a sharp nod. There was a glint in his eye that was calculating as he gestured for Izuku to begin playing.

The two influential men began their conversation on the couch as Izuku held up his violin.

Part of Izuku was curious as to what they were discussing, but the other part of Izuku didn't care.

Tomura was always closing deals, making connections, and ensuring that The Viper Academy was a staple of the underground. He'd done a successful job at establishing them as more of a crime family than a business these days.

Izuku began to play the alluring music that was on the sheet. He knew this song well, it was Tomura's favorite. Dark and eerie. The melody of the song drowned out all conversation that could reach his ears. Slowly, Izuku was lulled into a trance that carried him elsewhere. Izuku

kept his eyes trained on the music sheet as he played, but he imagined himself somewhere else.

Whenever he played the violin, Izuku thought of Kacchan.

It was involuntary but he accepted his haunting in stride. Without fail, he could visibly see the old plaza the way it used to be. He could see the two of them holding hands in a hazy memory below the broken angel and hear The Dance of The Lovebirds so clearly.

Izuku smiled slightly. He enjoyed the comfort that one good year of his life brought him.

When he arrived at the end of the song, Izuku snapped out of his imagination.

Several Yakuza members in the room clapped, and others paid him no mind and continued to drink. The weak applause was almost laughable. Izuku immediately began playing the next song, and curiously turned his eyes to his brother.

Izuku almost messed up his note. Both Chisaki and Tomura were staring deeply into him. Neither man was talking. Heat began to burn at Izuku's cheeks from the unusual attention.

Then Chisaki cocked his head and gave him a small wave.

Izuku blushed and quickly cut his eyes back to the music sheet.

ᔓᔓᔓ

After about an hour of sitting through the suffocating smell of cigarettes, cigars, and liquor, the meeting concluded.

Izuku stopped playing when Chisaki stood up and straightened out his jacket. The simple gesture was like pulling puppet strings on all his men. They all began packing up their things.

Izuku stayed seated and waited for Tomura's signal. It was then that Chisaki held out his hand for Tomura to shake. Tomura's eyes instantly sparked with fire. Like someone who conquered a long battle.

He shook Chisaki's hand in a firm handshake, and bowed his head respectfully.

Tomura then cut his eyes to Izuku.

Izuku stared back at him patiently, ready to leave. But he didn't get his wish when Tomura walked away towards the back of the room. Izuku watched as his brother began chatting with the second in command of the Yakuza. Tomura gestured to the man behind the bar and they started making drinks and chatting.

Chisaki then walked straight up to Izuku.

Izuku looked up. Chisaki was smiling at him a little too nicely.

“You play beautifully,” Chisaki said first.

“Thank you, Mr. Chisaki,” Izuku said. He bowed his head and nervously shifted in his seat.

“Do you…like classical music a lot?” Chisaki asked.

Izuku nodded his head. “I do. It’s my favorite type of music.”

“Would you enjoy events like symphonies or masquerade balls then?”

Izuku looked around and noticed a couple of Yakuza members stealing glances at them. Izuku smiled the best he could before answering.

“I suppose I would, Mr. Chisaki,” Izuku said honestly. “I’ve never been to one.”

“Please, call me Kai,” Chisaki corrected and laughed a little. “No need to be so formal all the time.”

He pulled a seat up next to Izuku and scooted in closely. Izuku froze fully, entirely taken back. He never got personal with Chisaki—that was something only Tomura ever did. He was nervous and unsure how to exactly speak with a client. Izuku glanced at Tomura whose back turned towards them.

“Try it,” Chisaki commanded with an unnerving smile. “Call me *Kai*.”

Izuku opened his mouth hesitantly.

“Ka…Kai,” Izuku whispered.

The name against his tongue immediately tasted wrong, like rotten boiled eggs. Izuku averted his eyes, cleared his throat, and focused on the violin in his lap.

“Sorry,” Izuku quickly apologized. “I am not used to addressing you that way, Mr. Chisaki.”

“Hah. Don’t worry.” Chisaki laughed. “I’ll get you used to calling me Kai soon. I had a feeling you would be shy about it.”

Izuku was about to ask what *that* meant—but he got his answer.

Without a word, Chisaki leaned in close. Their shoulders touched and Chisaki’s hand stroked his thigh. Izuku nearly jumped out of his seat.

“You’re very sweet,” Chisaki whispered. “I’ll try my best to be gentle with you.”

Izuku’s first instinct was to break Chisaki’s wrist.

Izuku’s second instinct was his self preservation. It grabbed a hold of him and reminded him that this was the most powerful man in the country. Breaking Chisaki’s wrist would guarantee Izuku’s neck being snapped within a millisecond.

Izuku steadily grew disquieted as Chisaki's gaze roamed his body. Izuku cut his eyes towards Tomura. His older brother was watching them. His cold eyes were locked onto the hand resting against Izuku's thigh. Izuku waited for his brother to step in like usual—

—but Tomura did nothing.

He turned away.

Izuku's blood ran cold when it all clicked together.

The hand on Izuku's thigh squeezed tenderly and then Chisaki stood up. Chisaki gestured with his head for his men to leave. Like loyal ants they all followed. One by one each Yakuza member lined up and poured out of the private lounge. Chisaki and his second in command were the last ones of the Yakuza left.

Right as Chisaki was about to exit, he stopped in the doorway.

He glanced happily at Izuku. Then glanced thankfully at Tomura.

"Pleasure doing business with you, Tomura," Chisaki said with a head bow.

ᔓᔓᔓ

The whole walk home an emotion like simmering coal forged in Izuku. It burned from the bottom of his spirit and crawled up his skin. It started at his legs then passed his stomach to sit at his throat. Dread made Izuku's throat swell until it burned.

Tomura didn't bother to acknowledge him and it infuriated Izuku. His brother stared forward the whole time, walking slightly ahead with the three dogs. The two brothers stayed silent the entire walk, until they arrived back home.

When the door to their penthouse closed shut, that burning emotion ripped right out of Izuku's throat.

"What did you *do*?" Izuku harshly whispered.

Tomura's expression barely changed. He pressed his lips into a contemplative line. He ignored Izuku as he gave his dogs treats and patted their heads. When the three animals wandered off to their corner of the living room, Tomura turned and glared at him.

"What I *did* was secure The Viper Academy's future," Tomura answered. "I finally obtained a seat at the Tokyo Underground Council after five years of hard work."

"In exchange for *what*?" Izuku pushed.

He stared deeply into his brother's cold eyes with a profound sense of anger.

"A couple of things," Tomura finally admitted with a sigh. He crossed his arms and lowered his head away from Izuku. "In exchange for the seat he wanted access to all my connections.

I needed to do extra tasks for him like kill off budding rival gangs. Additionally he wanted a payment. Of course, I couldn't come up with the dollar amount he proposed."

Tomura licked his dry lips.

"I knew there was one more option," Tomura whispered. "Chisaki has an obsession with…*purity*. I knew his interest in you doubled when your skin cleared. Then his interest tripled when I told him how you were untouched. So I asked him if he would be interested in buying your virginity to cover the gap in payment. He agreed, happily."

The floor beneath Izuku's feet felt like it gave.

Tomura glanced at him with pity, but there was zero regret in his eyes.

"It's all been signed, and the seat will be officially mine after consummation," Tomura continued. "When he calls on you, I'll let you know. I know this isn't ideal, but I promise you it'll be worth it soon enough."

"How much?" Izuku whispered.

"That's not important—"

"—Tell me," Izuku demanded and his voice cracked. "How *much*?"

"Eighty million yen," Tomura answered reluctantly. "Be flattered, most assassin's virginities go for just three million. I'll get you something nice with the money as a thank you. But in the meantime, you need to get your beauty rest. We can go over everything in the morning at breakfast. Goodnight, Izuku."

Tomura turned on his heels.

When his back was facing Izuku, the ghost of Hiryu appeared. Hiryu was glaring a hole through Tomura's skull and his expression was twisted in hate. His nostrils flared in defiance.

"*No*," Hiryu's phantom said.

Tomura stopped walking.

He looked over his shoulder with a sharpened glare.

"What did you say?" Tomura questioned.

Izuku blinked.

Then he recognized he was the one who said 'No.'

Tomura turned towards him. His face was apprehensive at Izuku's outright refusal. When their gazes clashed, a new emotion in Izuku's spine hardened. It molded into his muscles at the realization he was the one to talk back.

Like mist being blown away, the imagery of Hiryu faded. The illusion vanished to show Izuku it was really *himself* glaring hatefully at Tomura.

Tomura was taken back by the depraved leer.

Izuku immediately fixed his face but didn't change his mind.

"I-I said no," Izuku repeated. "There has to be something else he would want, I'm n-not agreeing to that."

Tomura scoffed and dismissively waved his hand. "Izuku. This is a seat at the Underground Tokyo Council in exchange for a single *fuck*. Think of the bigger picture here."

Izuku took a step back and shook his head. "Tomura, *please*. I-I don't want to do *that*—N-Not with Chisaki—"

"Why? Because he's not *blond*?" Tomura jabbed cruelly.

"That's not it," Izuku whispered. "I don't like Chisaki in that way."

"I know I said everyone has their preferences, but *please,* spare me the spoiled brat speech," Tomura exasperated. "This is the *Yakuza heir* we're talking about. One of the most powerful men in Japan. This is the closest thing to romance you'll *get*. Maybe if you're lucky he'll buy you again and it'll bud into some sort of ritual. I would allow you to date, if it was Chisaki."

"But I don't want him," Izuku said solidly. He blinked through the tears in his eyes as he clutched his shirt. "This is *my* body we're talking about, Tomura—"

"—It's not *your* body," Tomura snapped. "Don't you get it by now? Your opinion doesn't matter. Your desires and happiness do not *matter*. You're a *viper,* not a person. Your body has *never* been yours. Nine owned it before and now *I* own it."

Gradually, that feeling of simmering coal strengthened in Izuku's chest.

It burned hotter each passing second he dared to keep eye contact with his brother.

"Izuku," Tomura warned. He lowered his voice to a threatening octave as his eyes darkened. "I'm doing this for the better of both of us, you know that right? When I get this seat, we won't have to be at the whim of clients all the time—we can call the shots. All you have to do is take it like a whore for *one* night. You're going to do it, and you're going to do it happily. Are we clear?"

No. They weren't.

Izuku never considered how he would lose his virginity. He'd forgotten it was still at risk of it being taken after this long. It was the one thing that belonged to him—something The Academy never possessed. Only him.

"I said—are we *clear*?" Tomura asked when Izuku stayed silent too long.

Izuku's breathing slowly became heavy. His nostrils flared as his glare deepened. The longer he looked into Tomura's eyes, the more he felt betrayed and used.

Tomura sauntered up to Izuku. He hooked his finger under Izuku's shirt collar and pulled down to expose his mark. The simple motion was a bitter slap in the face—but what Tomura said next triggered Izuku like nothing else.

"*217*, I said, are we clear?" Tomura hissed.

Izuku snapped.

His arm reeled back as he did the unthinkable: he punched Tomura dead in the face.

The full strength he used snapped Tomura's head to the side and the tears in his eyes fell. A visceral cathartic feeling poured out of him, extending into the punch. He mourned the thought of the last thing that was *his* being stolen from him.

Izuku swung again through his blurry vision. This time however Tomura caught his wrist. His brother twisted his arm unnaturally backwards. It inflicted excruciating pain but Izuku gritted his teeth through it. Izuku used his other hand to swipe at Tomura's face. He clawed straight down and drew fresh blood.

Tomura yelled shrilly in bloodcurdling agony.

"You ungrateful fucking *brat*," Tomura spat and he flung Izuku down to the floor.

Izuku began to scramble upright but quickly Tomura straddled him and pushed him back down. They struggled back and forth with Izuku biting, kicking, and scratching. Tomura violently shook Izuku, slamming him against the floor. Their whirlwind shook the furniture with their loud crashes and bumps.

Immediately the three dogs began barking loudly, adding to the noise.

Izuku twisted his body, trying to escape. He screamed, "Get off me!" as he reeled back his elbow and sharply struck Tomura in his nose.

A sick crack filled the space.

Blood trickled down Tomura's nose and he grew furious. His expression sunk into destructive anger as he tried to force Izuku down in submission. He clawed his hands into Izuku's hair and roughly pushed Izuku's face into the carpet and dragged him.

Izuku tried to shake Tomura off with all he could. The burn of the carpet scraped against his cheek as he tried to struggle away. But his brother over powered him and pinned him down with his pelvis pressed directly against his backside.

"Is *this* how you would rather lose your virginity?" Tomura hissed violently. He tightened his grip on Izuku's curls until he was ripping out several hairs. "Eating carpet like your goddamn mother did when she fucking conceived you? Hah?! Because *that* can be arranged and you would have *wished* it was Chisaki."

“I said g-get off!” Izuku screamed.

“—‘Zuku?” A tiny voice whispered.

Both Izuku and Tomura halted.

Izuku’s eyes went wide as he looked up. Standing on the staircase was Katsuma. His big eyes were wearily looking between the two of them. He was worried for Izuku and clearly scared of Tomura as he hid slightly behind the staircase bars.

“Go back to bed, Katsuma,” Tomura commanded.

Katsuma didn’t move. He glanced at Izuku.

“Do—Do as he says, Katsuma,” Izuku said with a comforting smile. “I’ll be upstairs in a minute.”

Katsuma hesitantly went back up the stairs. He glanced backwards several times and then shut the door to his room.

Izuku’s body sagged, and he rested his throbbing head into the brittle carpet.

Tomura roughly exhaled and recollected himself. He let go of Izuku and sat back on his hunches. Izuku rolled over and sat up, still glaring at Tomura. Tomura wiped the blood from his injuries and snarled when he saw how much damage Izuku inflicted to his face—*yet again*.

“If you don’t do this, Izuku, I *will* hurt Katsuma,” Tomura threatened coldly.

Izuku stiffened. “You wouldn’t. He’s *my* little—”

“—Oh, but I *would*,” Tomura cruelly promised. “He’s about the age where Nine would start sending kids to the basement for punishments. Maybe he’s old enough to start taking your punishments for you. Is that what you want?”

Tomura stood up and his shadow fell over Izuku. He knew Katsuma was one of Izuku’s weak points.

Izuku’s stomach twisted in knots and it was like cotton had been shoved in his throat. He gripped the carpet beneath his fingers in pure, unchecked rage—but there was nothing he could do. He was powerless against Tomura. He was *always* powerless.

“Don’t hurt him.” Izuku finally lowered his head in submission. “I’ll do it. Just don’t touch him.”

“Glad you see it my way,” Tomura said. He wiped his bleeding lip and shook his head. “Good night, Izuku.”

“Good night,” Izuku whispered from his clenched jaw.

“Good night—*what*?” Tomura hissed.

Deep resentment flickered in Izuku’s heart but he didn’t show it.

He pulled his lips to say the rancid words, “Goodnight, Big Brother.”

Izuku walked into Katsuma’s room feeling numb.

Katsuma was still wide awake in his bed. The loud noises and screams must’ve terrified him. Katsuma’s big brown eyes were full of tears and red at the rims. When he laid eyes on Izuku, Katsuma reached his arms up to him.

Izuku wordlessly walked over to Katsuma and crawled into the tiny bed with him.

Katsuma began crying softly and Izuku stroked his hair until he fell back asleep. As Izuku listened to Katsuma’s tiny sniffles fade, he thought about his place in the giant machine that was The Viper Academy. He tried to envision himself as a dutiful, working clog.

Izuku tried to picture if he could stand back idly when the time came for Katsuma to start his brutal training.

The basement. The lashes. The Cull. The poison. The pain that only produced more pain. It was a cruel, vicious cycle that would never be broken once Katsuma got his mark. The original fate he had of a warm home would be buried, and his hands would be soaked in red forever.

A dangerous resolve settled into Izuku.

He saw a vision of a giant viper made of stone, slithering around in circles. It endlessly ate its own tail with the help of them all being new additions to keep it growing. The body grew longer with the help of Ibara. The help of Jin. Hiryu. Himiko. Sen. Aoyama. Kota. Eri. Everyone. Every new addition was a new link in the chain that kept the viper spinning. And sitting at the head commanding them to be eaten was Tomura.

Resentment boiled Izuku’s blood when he envisioned Katsuma being another link in the chain.

Izuku was going to drive a wedge straight into the cycle and snap its neck, even if it was the last thing he did.

“I’ll get you out,” Izuku promised in a whisper. “You’re going to go back to your family.”

When Katsuma and Tomura were fast asleep, Izuku took a long walk around their large home.

He wandered the sterile white hallways like a forgotten shadow. He passed the classrooms. The dorm rooms. He passed the suites where many of the other vipers lived. Izuku stared at all the different white doors that were designated for their life.

He held his hands in front of him as he studied his palms. All he could see was venomous sin. It was too late for him. There was no saving him from this fate but Katsuma was truly pure. There were people out there who loved him, unlike Izuku.

Izuku's brain tried to search for an answer to free Katsuma and all the other children. But nothing came to mind right away. He desperately needed *time*. He needed a shit ton of time to break into the records, track down each family, and then deliver each kid to their rightful home.

But *how*?

As Izuku was walking, he came up upon Tomura's office that was once Nine's. The golden double doors were shut tight but a dim, yellow light was pouring out from beneath them.

Izuku cautiously slowed his stride.

Who was inside if Tomura was in bed asleep?

Izuku glanced behind him once, then quietly walked up to the doors. He stayed light on his feet as he crouched down. He pressed his ear against the door, surprised to hear two faint voices chatting inside.

"I haven't been able to reach Peter Moore in years," One said. "That white devil continually dodges my inquiries and last we spoke he threatened to breach the NDA he signed. For that alone, he needs to be eliminated."

"Have you discussed this with the Governor?" Ms. Nagant asked. "Surely he will take care of it."

"Unfortunately the Governor doesn't accept direct calls from me at this time," One huffed. "It's an election year. To protect himself, he doesn't converse with me during election season. I'm afraid we're on our own. I have no way of knowing if the Governor plans to eliminate Peter Moore, so we need to do it ourselves to cover our bases."

"Good call," Ms. Nagant hummed. "Well, I received information that he's hiding under the name of Henry Sekai. He left the Americas to come to Japan under a new identity as a romance specialist. He even has a ridiculous resort called Ai no Rakuen that he's now using to lure people into human trafficking."

"Hm. Would it be easy to get close to him?"

"No," Ms. Nagant said unhappily. "The resort is full of his operations and security. It would take effort to get close to him and snuff him out."

One tapped his fingers against a wooden surface. "I will probably ask one of my top vipers to do this as soon as possible, but I am unsure which. We can finish this conversation tomorrow

when I consult Tomura on who I should choose."

Footsteps began approaching the door and Izuku quickly backtracked around a corner. He ducked into the shadows as the double doors opened.

Izuku digested the information as he gained an idea.

ɯɯɯ

When Izuku went back to their penthouse, he lay awake in his bed. He was on his laptop researching Ai no Rakuen to death.

Love's Paradise.

When he saw it was located in sunny Okinawa, Izuku's chest filled with butterflies. He'd never been to Okinawa. He knew there was a subtle blueness in that statement considering its where he and Kacchan planned so foolishly to run away too. It was also the location of the romance novel he was in love with.

Izuku's curiosity was fully hooked as he looked at the palm trees on his screen. With every scroll, he was bombarded with pastel colors of pink, red, and purple. And with every click, his eyes lit up.

Couples' massages? Pool side mingling? Beach picnics and romantic hiking?

Izuku could barely contain his smile. It was *perfect*.

Izuku's heart clutched with guilty pleasure as he stared at the glittering hearts on the website. What a shame this was really a human trafficking ploy. Izuku could easily see the allure. If he was a normal person, he probably would fall prey to this candy colored death trap.

Izuku bit his lip as he eyed the *In The Mood For Love* poster on his wall.

This could work to his advantage.

He needed time to make a plan on how to get Katsuma out. But if he could do that before Chisaki claimed his virginity, even better.

Only Kami knew what kind of chaos would spread over Tokyo the day Tomura gained control of that seat. The power he would possess had the potential to exceed One's.

Izuku could envision Tomura's vengeful hand splaying across the council table. He imagined blackness seeping from Tomura's fingertips like spilled ink and into the cracks. The flesh of the table would rot like gangrene and slowly the whole city would be consumed. One by one every citizen in Tokyo would be swallowed into the empty blackhole that was Tomura until nothing was left.

If Tomura got that seat, Izuku knew he could kiss any dreams of freedom for Katsuma and the other kids goodbye.

When the morning came Izuku took a page out of Tomura's playbook: he bypassed the middle man and went straight for One.

He learned from Tomura at breakfast that One was in town for the week. One would be working out of Tomura's office that was a floor below their penthouse. That was code for 'be on your best behavior and don't embarrass me'. Izuku took the hint and Katsuma quietly hunched into himself.

While Tomura was in the shower, Izuku snuck into Tomura's room.

He quickly fed the three dogs treats so they wouldn't bark. Next he peeked through his brother's planner. He thumbed the pages quickly until he found the current date. He saw the crammed schedule and read Tomura was meeting with One in exactly forty minutes.

Izuku skipped his shower and threw on his clothes.

He jogged lightly to the office and took a deep breath. His hands were shaking as he realized this was his first step in trying to out maneuver Tomura. There would be no turning back after this.

With all the bravery he possessed, Izuku knocked on the door. One's deep voice commanded for him to come in. Izuku smiled disarmingly as he pushed open the doors.

"Izuku, welcome," One said while scribbling in a notebook. "What can I help you with today?"

Izuku went straight to the point. He held his chin up high as he looked One in the eye. "I wanted to offer up my services to kill Peter Moore for you, sir. It would bring me great pleasure."

"And how do you know I need Peter Moore killed?" One questioned curiously.

"I…overheard you last night," Izuku shamefully admitted.

One clicked his pen and sat it down. "Eavesdropping is typically frowned upon."

"Sorry, sir," Izuku said quickly. He pushed through his nerves to remain calm. "But I did some research and I would be the best person for this job. I have an appearance that makes people instinctively underestimate me. Along with that, I can blend in effortlessly to the romantic resort scene because of my unsuspecting appearance and demeanor."

One raised a brow, clearly impressed and taken back at the forwardness. But One liked proactive Vipers.

"What would make you better for this job over Jin or Ibara? They are more experienced in espionage than you."

“Jin and Ibara both have the mark of the viper,” Izuku pointed out. “I am the only top viper that is not tattooed. Moore may see the viper tattoos on their skin and become immediately suspicious. He knows too much about us to not think anything about snake imagery. However, I can simply put a bandaid over my number and he’d never know I was from The Academy.”

One then looked down at his own hands.

Both his knuckles were graced with a simplistic viper tattoo. It snaked its way between his fingers to run across his hand. He wiggled his appendages rhythmically to make it dance.

“You have a fair point,” One agreed. “Do you think you can get on top of this soon? I have a trip to Czechia this weekend. I would like to have that roach killed by the time I come back.”

Izuku nodded and put on a sickly sweet smile. “I can head out within the hour, sir.”

“Hah!” One smiled. He clapped his large hands together with a thunder-like boom. “I like your eagerness to kill. You remind me of myself a bit.”

Izuku bowed his head. “That’s the highest compliment any viper could ever be told.”

One began pulling out paperwork and invited Izuku to take a seat in the chair across from him. They chatted idly for a while, ironing out details. Izuku shared all his knowledge about the resort he conjured up last night. One jotted down various information and nodded his head.

When the ink was dry, One took a second to study him. He tilted his head and his eyes honed in on Izuku’s hair.

“Your hair is a very unique shade of dark green,” One said suddenly. “I’ve only ever seen it once before.”

There was a weight to his words that made Izuku contemplative. But Inko appeared in his mind and he immediately shoved her back down.

Right as Izuku was about to respond, the doors behind him opened. Both Izuku and One turned their heads to see Tomura entering with paperwork in hand.

Tomura’s expression tightened to surprise upon seeing Izuku.

“Am I late for the debrief?” Tomura asked slowly. He glanced at One. “I wasn’t aware Izuku was joining us as well.”

“You’re not late at all,” One reassured. He leaned over the desk and grinned. “Izuku here made an impromptu visit. He offered to kill Peter Moore for me starting today.”

Tomura’s mouth hung open slightly, entirely blindsided. “I—I was not aware of this assignment.”

He cut his eyes at Izuku and Izuku kept an innocent expression. He decided quickly he needed to begin using his doe eyes for more than assignments if he was going to outwit Tomura.

“The meeting I called you for today was going to discuss the Peter Moore situation,” One said. “I was going to consult you about who would be the best assassin for the job, but Izuku already informed me it would be him.”

“This is a job Ibara can do,” Tomura countered.

“Ah. Well. Izuku pointed out that Ibara has the mark of the viper,” One said. He held up his right hand to emphasize his point and wiggled his fingers. “Izuku is the only one who would be able to go undercover for this close up mission fully without being detected. And I don’t trust any lower ranked viper with this assignment.”

Tomura’s lips pressed so tightly before saying, “but Izuku is needed here.”

“For what?” One questioned. “What could be more important than getting rid of that vermin?”

Izuku and One both waited for an answer.

Izuku knew the answer was selling his virginity to Chisaki. But did One?

Based on Tomura’s immediate silence—Izuku concluded One didn’t have a clue about the under the table deal. Which was information Izuku could use to his own advantage. Tomura was keeping the table seat a secret from One. This meant he wouldn’t dare force Izuku into Chisaki’s bed as long as he was on assignments that One knew about.

“Actually, it’s not that important,” Tomura backtracked. He gave a shallow bow at the waist and smiled curtly. “Izuku would be the best choice for the job.”

“Great!” One exclaimed. “Glad we’re all on the same page. Izuku, begin to pack your things. You’re heading to Okinawa today. Remember, take out Moore quietly. Leave no trace behind.”

One handed him a heavy red folder with a smile.

The weight of the folder in Izuku’s hands felt like the first step to Katsuma’s freedom.

ɯɯɯ

As Izuku packed his bags, Tomura loomed in his doorway with folded arms.

“You can delay the inevitable but it is still the inevitable,” Tomura spat. “Fate is fate.”

Izuku looked over his shoulder innocently. He stared Tomura dead in the eyes and played coy the best he could.

“I’m not delaying anything, Big Brother,” Izuku said naively and gave a gentle gaze. “I walked by and heard One talking about Moore and did what any Viper would do. I offered my services.” Izuku bowed his head to add to the act. “I know you know best and only mean well with me and Chisaki. When I come back, I will be happy to do my duty to help secure the seat for you.”

Tomura’s suspicions softened at the words. It was exactly what he wanted to hear. Izuku knew this because it was exactly the opposite of what he felt.

Tomura nodded, deciding that this was simply a blip in his road to power. He exhaled tiredly through his nose and walked to stand next to Izuku. He picked up one of the pink shirts Izuku picked out and began folding it.

“Try to make this a quick assignment,” Tomura whispered. He placed the shirt in the suitcase with care. “Chisaki isn’t known for his patience.”

Izuku nodded with a plastic smile. “I’ll come back in a few days, tops.”

ᔓᔓᔓ

First Day in Paradise

The scenery was more breathtaking than Izuku could ever imagine. He heard all the rumors about how captivating Okinawa was. He’d seen the pictures. But no photograph or words did it justice. The crisp blue sky felt bluer and the palm trees were standing taller than most he’d ever seen. The turning tides looked as if they were waving to him from over the horizon.

With the first step off the private jet, a strange breeze blew through.

It was steadfast and nearly took Izuku’s sun hat with it. Izuku lightly yelped as he grabbed the straw hat and pulled it back on top of his head firmly. He steadied himself and began making his way to the resort.

Okay, he told himself in a small prep talk. *Kill Moore quickly, rest up, and come up with a game plan in the extra days. No getting distracted.*

Izuku settled into his resolve as he lugged his giant, pink luggage behind him.

He took the first taxi he could find and read through the decorated pamphlet as he rode inside. A delicate blush covered his cheeks as he read the brochure. There were many pictures of couples on the inside and it was packaged perfectly to sell romance.

Maybe…a small distraction wouldn’t hurt anything, Izuku reasoned. He could indulge a bit while he was here—it was basically like being directly transported into one of his novels.

There was no harm in participating in some of the activities.

Izuku walked into the dazzling resort with wide eyes and a full heart. He glanced around, taken back by the crowds. The lobby was densely packed with couples all holding hands and

singles ready to mingle. Every person was dressed in bright, lovely colors. It nearly made Izuku's eyes hurt by how much of a contrast this was from his usual sterile, colorless life.

He smiled longingly when he saw two women kiss and hold hands.

Okay, he was going to enjoy this more than he thought. How cool was this? He got to have a front row seat to *true love* for the first time in his life! As he watched the couple, he hoped one day Katsuma could have something normal like that. It was too late for him—his sins could never be forgiven but Katsuma's whole life was ahead of him.

Izuku took a spot in line and waited patiently. He reviewed his cover:

His name for the week was Hiroji Chiba. A young man from the countryside who was here on vacation by himself after a bad break up. Izuku planned on getting close to Moore by potentially flirting with the staff until he got more information about Moore's blindspots. Then he would execute his assignment from there.

The line was moving fluidly as Izuku reviewed his new persona. Then the line came to a halt when it was his turn to be serviced.

Suddenly, the bellhop ran off somewhere, leaving only an apology behind.

Izuku was a patient man so he didn't mind at first. But after a while, people behind him grew antsy. He peaked around, trying to figure out what was the hold up. But no one ever came to the front.

If he was into writing reviews, he would strike off one star for how long he was on his feet.

Then suddenly, the person behind him spoke.

"You have got to be shitting me," a voice Izuku was all too familiar with groaned.

Everything froze in time. The bird stopped chirping. The people stopped laughing. Several eyes crawled towards him and absolute *annoyance* trickled down Izuku's spine.

Slowly, he turned around to face his worst possible scenario.

Looming over him was the stranger from both his dreams and nightmares.

Over the last five years the stranger was a steady constant. They orbited around one another like they were each other's center of gravity. They were always fatally drawn together over and over. In their push and pull, Izuku got to watch the stranger grow into a dangerously beautiful human.

Every time Izuku was running away from this stranger, he noted the new differences. His sharp features grew stronger. His salient high cheekbones were fully refined. Even his eyes had grown more striking and the hue of his blonde hair only seemed more alluring.

Which helped *nothing*. This man was a flat out liability for such an important assignment.

“No,” Izuku said immediately. He shook his head quickly. “Nu-uh. I refuse. This is not happening—”

“—I agree, it’s not. You need to fucking leave in the next five seconds,” The stranger barked.

Immediately Izuku bristled. “I’m not going anywhere. Why are you here!?”

“*Me*?! What the fuck are *you* doing here! If you’re here to screw up another one of my marks I swear—”

“—I’m not the one always sticking his gun in other people’s business!”

“Yes, the fuck you do—” The stranger paused and closed his eyes in a poor attempt to calm his illy controlled temper. He ran his hands down his face in disbelief. “Please tell me you’re here because you’re some dumbass hopeless romantic and not because you’re here on an assignment.”

Izuku spluttered, unsure what to say in public. As he was tongue tied, the stranger spoke up again.

“I’m not going to argue with you, Deku. You’re going to listen carefully and follow what I say and *leave*.”

“*I* need to leave?” Over his dead body. If he went back to Tokyo now, Tomura would strip him naked, put a bow on his ass and drop him in front of Chisaki’s doorstep. “I was here first!”

“Oh shut up, we’re not five!”

“I swear if this ends up like that time we were in Taiwan I’m going to *actually* murder you.”

The stranger’s lip curled. He glared at Izuku until his eyes narrowed into dagger-like slits. He leaned down to face Izuku at eye level until his breath was against his lips.

“As if you have the guts to kill me.”

Izuku halted all together and his eyes widened. All the times he failed to pull the trigger stacked up in front of him. The stranger’s eyes were so downright vicious it made Izuku’s heart skip a beat.

…Did the stranger somehow know about his weakness?

“—Well, what do we have here!” A booming voice cut through the tension.

Both men stiffened and turned their eyes to the counter. Waiting there was a tall man in a white suit with a golden White Dove pin on his collar. He had pinkly fair skin, brown hair, and light brown eyes. Izuku bit his tongue when he recognized the newcomer immediately.

It was Peter Moore. His mark.

The unsuspecting target laughed and gestured to them to come up all the way to the counter. Both Izuku and his stranger glanced discreetly at each other. The look read ‘go along with it’. It was clear the stranger knew who this was as well.

Izuku stood up straight as they awkwardly walked up to the counter together.

“I’m so sorry that no one has come to the counter yet,” Moore said. “But I have to just say you two are hilarious. You remind me of me and my wife at your age, ha! Always at each other’s throats, we’ve also been to Taiwan. Lovely place.”

Izuku nearly choked and the stranger next to him fumbled slightly.

Moore was *listening* to their squabble?

“You are married, right?” Moore questioned with a minor frown when Izuku and the stranger didn’t say anything. The affection in his eyes faded to be replaced with sharp suspicion. “You two fight as though you’ve been together for ten years, if not how do you two know each other?”

“Y-Yes!” Izuku quickly said. “W-We are, um—”

Izuku looked up at the stranger, trying to search for an answer to this awkward situation. In a split second, red eyes transported him back to when he was a child. He envisioned him and Kacchan creating wedding bands from old strings.

“This…is my husband,” Izuku said suddenly.

Silence.

Shit.

The word ‘husband’ slipped out before he could catch it. Izuku wanted to slap himself for blurting out that word. Why hadn’t he said *boyfriend*? Or *date*? He quickly pinned a forced smile across his face and luckily for him, the stranger got the hint as well.

“Yup,” The stranger quickly agreed. He smiled so fake Izuku was sure he’d turn into a Ken doll right there. “Verbal berating is our own special way of affection. Excuse anything you may have heard.”

“Yeah, you know how it is,” Izuku chuckled playfully. He reached up and pinched the stranger’s cheek hard since he couldn’t slap him like he wanted to. “Sometimes you just really...*really* want to wring your spouse’s neck after so many years together.”

When Peter Moore laughed, Izuku wanted to die.

He wasn’t going to make it back to Tokyo in a single piece. He engaged in light conversation with Peter Moore and his curse of a stranger.

His target smiled too happily at them and asked, “What name is the reservation under?”

“—Bakugou is our last name,” The stranger suddenly said. “It should be under Taro Bakugou.”

Izuku held himself back from scoffing.

Taro Bakugou. What a fake sounding name. It was baffling to Izuku that the stranger couldn’t even pick a name that sounded the *least* bit real. Whose last name was *Bakugou*?

He glanced at the stranger and the stranger glanced at him.

Tomura always warned him about distractions. His elder brother frequently emphasized how a single gust of wind can knock an entire fleet off its course.

And this guy was a typhoon waiting to happen.



A typhoon was an understatement.

The stranger was a combination of an earthquake, wildfire, and tsunami wrapped into one ill tempered blond. He was abnormally large and possessed a crazy amount of strength. What’s more, he seemed to be fueled by sheer will power and not training.

He was a unique type of natural disaster—but a *disaster* nonetheless.

Immediately upon entering their room, the stranger forced Izuku up against the wall. It was a terrible mix of frightening and exciting because of how easily he hoisted Izuku up. But Izuku couldn’t even focus on that. If this stranger was here that means Izuku’s assignment would get blown—it *always* got blown when red eyes and blond hair were involved.

And to confirm what he said, their fighting unwillingly drew the attention of Peter Moore.

“Is everything okay in there?” Moore called from the other side of the door. “There was a call from your neighbors to the front desk about fighting.”

That was like a bucket of cold water on both of them.

Quickly, Izuku realized they needed to make nice if he wanted any hopes of surviving the week. Katsuma’s freedom was in the balance. That alone calmed Izuku enough to think clearly through his mental block and begin to put on his charm.

“Y-Yes, we’re fine!” Izuku quickly said and answered the door. “I’m so sorry about that! We didn’t mean to make so much noise.”

Upon coming face to face with Moore a second time, Izuku immediately saw the distrust.

Moore’s eyes were kind but behind his facade was deathly intent. He knew he was wanted in more than four countries and pissed off who knows how many people. He was keen on his examination of Izuku and *Taro*.

His eyes landed on their empty ring fingers.

Izuku mentally cursed himself for blurting out *husband*. How could they be husbands without wedding rings? Quickly, Izuku put on his naive face and played cute enough to shoo Peter Moore away. When his mark was out of ear shot, Izuku decided he needed to plead his case and make nice.

"...That man is my mark. I have orders to take him out quietly," Izuku admitted.

This was a risky move. But this was the *one* assignment he absolutely could *not* fuck up.

The stranger's angry expression faltered. He looked sideways at Izuku and said, "Seriously?"

"Yeah," Izuku reassured. He licked his lips, feeling like he was admitting something he shouldn't. But he'd do this for Katsuma. "He, um, crossed a higher up and my handler is demanding that he be put down."

"Well, I guess that works out for us both in whatever miracle," the stranger mumbled.

Izuku raised a brow. "And why do you say that?"

"My agency has been hired by two separate governments to take him out as well," the stranger explained carefully. "He's wanted in several countries dead or alive and it seems like everyone is leaning towards dead."

Izuku's mouth dropped slightly.

He stared at the stranger in utter surprise. For once this guy *wasn't* guarding someone? Miracle was an understatement.

It felt like fate was smiling right down on Izuku for the first time.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When they went to dinner later that night, Izuku was disquieted by how organized the seating was.

Every couple was assigned a group and were forced to stay within that group for the remainder of their overlapping vacations. To the innocent eye it seemed like a great way to build community. To Izuku, who was raised under Viper rule, the layout was a catalog.

Moore was keeping close track of his potential merchandise.

Which is why Izuku was only half surprised to find Moore at their table after their slip up.

"*Bakugous*!" Peter Moore greeted them through the dense crowd. "Over here! I saved you two seats!"

Peter Moore turned to them with a smile as fake as plastic that could cut.

When they approached, the other couples in their group introduced themselves one by one.

Momo and Jirou were two lovely girlfriends. Eijirou and Mina were the most athletic husband and wife duo possibly on the planet. And lastly, Shouto and Inasa were a pair of husbands. But there was something slightly *off* about them. They were surveying him and the stranger as if they pinned something wasn't quite right about them as well.

Which opened the door to the hot spot.

From the moment Izuku and his fake husband sat down, every question was a careful probe:

Where were their rings? What happened in Taiwan? How did they meet?

Izuku answered everything fluidly, fully leaning into his fake husband role. He placed some truth into his lie, because the best lie was always based on real events. He was doing well, and had everyone hooked around his finger until his stranger interjected with a surprising addition.

"He came into my life quickly," the stranger muttered after being asked how they met. "Quick and fast like an annoying little bullet you can't see coming."

Izuku felt immediate disillusionment and confusion.

The gentleness slapped Izuku with various encounters of their 'truces'. He was reminded of all the tiny touches that conflicted with the stranger's personality. This was supposed to be them faking a marriage—but that tone of voice was not fake.

"I meant…when he first came up to me, Hiroji's presence shocked me, y'know?" The stranger continued suddenly. "I'm no good at that mushy crap but, uh. He was dressed in all red. Not that cheap cherry red color either. No, he was dressed in a really elegant shade of red—like expensive wine—a deep crimson."

He remembered what I was wearing?

That was a detail even Izuku forgot.

"The color highlighted his eyes," the stranger continued. "When he looked at me, I felt like his gaze had pierced through me—like a bullet. I had no way of anticipating him." The stranger turned to him and held eye contact as he said, "It was hard not to want to know someone's name after that."

Intense scarlet eyes bored into him and Izuku's stale heart fluttered to life.

"So, you two meeting *was* incredibly romantic," Mina sighed with a large daydreamy expression. "I knew it had to be something absolutely stunning! Ahh, I wish me and Ei had met with something like that. I had gotten lucky and swiped right on him on Tinder while drunk."

"Yeah," Izuku whispered quietly.

He urgently turned away, not daring to look at the stranger at that moment. If he stared too long he worried he might breathe back to life his infatuation. He worked so hard to bury it in the last five years. It would be especially cruel to torture himself with something he couldn't have—especially *here*.

Throughout the rest of the dinner, Izuku discreetly glanced longingly at all the real couples.

ᔓᔓᔓ

At the day's end, Izuku's morbid curiosity about the stranger resuscitated despite his best efforts.

All through the dinner he couldn't get that monologue out of his head. It was something about the way his stranger spoke about him. So gentle, yet rough.

Which is why when they were in bed that night Izuku said, "Um, I think we should start getting to know each other. You know, for the mission. In case we get asked more questions we should be prepared."

It wasn't for the mission, entirely.

He learned his fake husband was born in Tokyo, but didn't live there anymore. Izuku soaked in that fact. That was closer than he thought. What's more curious is that the stranger was from old San'ya. That's where he met Kacchan at the plaza of the broken angel.

It was another overlap.

Lopsided smile. Blond hair. Red eyes. Now San'ya?

Odd.

Izuku fiddled with his fingers the more information he learned. The stranger's favorite color was green. He was the same age. He liked violin music as well. He used to be left-handed and now was right-handed. That was due to his mother believing old superstitions about left-handed people being bad luck. Every tiny piece of information cleared the fog that clouded the mysterious man.

Which left one last question:

"...Is your name really Taro?" Izuku asked quietly, his curiosity burning right through him.

The stranger immediately huffed and glared at him. "Go to bed. I'm not telling you my real name."

"I promise I won't use it against you. I'm only curious after all this time—"

"—I fucking said no." The stranger snapped. "Why the hell would I give you my real name when you've tried to kill me on several occasions and have fucking shot me countless times?"

Izuku stared at the stranger sadly.

“I’ve never tried to kill you,” Izuku said honestly.

He didn’t expect to be believed.

“Whatever. Just drop it,” the stranger said. The stranger turned over on the tiny couch and faced his back towards Izuku. “I don’t give out my real name to people in our line of work. *Especially* not people like you.”

“Right,” Izuku said tightly.

People like him: *a freak*.

He reminded himself what the stranger said all those years ago. This man didn’t like him one bit. He was tolerating him.

Izuku decided to get lost in his book after that. It was his coping mechanism. The comfort of that old story always helped distract him from any hurt he was feeling.

“That’s understandable. Sorry for asking,” Izuku muttered.

“Goodnight,” the stranger snapped. “And put the fucking book away. Reading in the dark is bad for your eyes and you need to stay sharp.”

Izuku would have listened if not for the fact he was reading his favorite part of the book. It was the scene where the two lovers finally accept each other fully and confess all their grief. It was here that Izuku assumed the lesson that forgiveness was the final act of love. From there, love could become *true* love. It’s why he adored this passage so much.

Then the gruff voice beside him said, “My real name is Katsuki.”

Izuku whipped his head to the stranger in surprise.

“Katsuki?” Izuku parroted, testing the name.

Something far in the back of Izuku’s head tugged. He tried to follow where that pull originated, but found himself lost in his memories. Everything was tangled together in a mess of blood, torture, and all the atrocities Izuku witnessed in his life.

But he nearly dropped his book at how perfectly Katsuki could translate to *Kacchan* as a nickname.

How cruel of fate to make sure that everything always led back to that boy he no longer knew. It made his chest feel tight. Katsuki turned around and Izuku could barely blink. When he registered that he was staring, Izuku cleared his throat.

“That’s a nice name,” Izuku stammered out. “I-It suits you very well.”

“Now, what’s your name?” Katsuki asked. “I know it’s not Hiroji.”

Izuku smiled at how Katsuki was glaring at him. Much like a Pomeranian trying to intimidate someone but there was no real bite behind it. Those red eyes looked at him a second too long and Izuku was sucked back into that damning gravity.

“I’m Izuku.”



Second Day in Paradise

When the next morning arrived Izuku couldn’t get the stranger’s real name out of his head.

Katsuki. Katsuki. *Katsuki*.

It was a beautiful name for a beautiful man.

Every time those scarlet eyes were on him, Izuku found himself weakened at the knees. It wasn’t good for him to be around Katsuki this long, he concluded. Being in the same room with Katsuki was affecting Izuku like toxic fumes to his brain.

And there was strain in the air every time silence fell between them.

Sometimes he found Katsuki’s eyes roaming his body or staring at his eyes a little too deeply. Katsuki probably wasn’t even aware of what he was doing, much less the effect it was having on Izuku.

Katsuki felt like temptation embodied.

Through his distracted haze, he was able to think clear just enough to scheme. They plotted to kill Moore with a murder-suicide. Izuku found himself hopeful that this debauched partnership might make the mission go quickly. The only hurdle they needed to jump was passing as husbands.

Which brought them to the first step: buying rings.

They chose gorgeous faux rings. An emerald gem for Katsuki’s ring and a ruby for Izuku’s. It was meant to represent them carrying each other’s eye color. It didn’t take Izuku any time to find the right shade of red to match Katsuki’s eyes. That shade of red had blown up his life a stupid number of times.

But he quickly learned, while Katsuki’s name was beautiful, he was a down right *asshole*.

He made fun of Izuku’s looks. His clothes. He even took a jab at Izuku for being a hopeless romantic. Katsuki couldn’t hold hands with him without putting up a fight.

To top it all off, every time Izuku spoke Katsuki followed it up with a snide comment.

“You look fucking hideous.”

“Stop looking at me with those creepy bug eyes of yours.”

“Romance is disgusting. Only fools believe in that shit.”

Katsuki was driving Izuku *insane*.

How did someone so handsome get cursed with such a foul mouth *and* attitude? By the time breakfast came, Izuku was at his wits end. And it wasn’t even ten o’ clock in the morning.

Izuku sat down to eat entirely disgruntled on the inside.

He unhappily forced a grin. He tried his best to focus on all the romantic things around him to lighten his mood. But it was hard with that *grainy* voice beside him saying something sarcastic. Izuku gave Katsuki a warning glare from the corner of his eye. But paused when he noticed that Katsuki was admiring the art on the ceiling.

Katsuki’s gaze was suddenly gentle.

Izuku furrowed his brow at this.

It was odd how quickly Katsuki could flip. One minute he was saying the most off the cuff statement, the next he was appreciating fine art. As Katsuki admired the mural, Izuku begrudgingly admired him.

“I see you’ve taken an interest in the painting above, Taro,” Moore cut in. “I commissioned it myself. It tells of this story I heard as a kid about two lovers.”

Izuku’s interest was piqued as he looked at Moore. Moore’s usual fake happy demeanor was dropped slightly as he looked up at the painting. Izuku finally turned his gaze up and was taken back at how extravagant the art was—but there was something sickening about it at the same time.

The painting was molding to the dome ceiling. The same two figures appeared throughout. One was an angel with blackened wings, and the other person was wingless, dressed in all white.

Izuku studied how the two figures interacted with each other. Soft touches. Gentle gazes.

“What’s the story’s name?” Katsuki asked curiously.

“Ah, I can’t recall the name personally.” Moore shrugged his shoulders. “It was told to me as a child, so bits of it escaped me and I could never come across it again. It’s morals stuck with my psyche so much that when I opened this place, I wanted to put it up in hopes maybe someone would recognize it.”

“I have never heard of anything resembling this,” Inasa said with a curious hum. “What’s it about?”

“It’s the love story of an angel and a sinner human,” Moore explained. “The painting shows them meeting, falling in love, and how other angels watched them care for each other.”

Izuku eyed the middle panel that was the two lovers kissing.

He tilted his head, liking the painting.

“What’s with that part right there?” Katsuki asked carefully. “It’s different from the rest.”

Izuku turned to the part of the painting Katsuki was looking at. It was dark, and vastly different from the rest of the painting. The angel with blackened wings was holding the figure dressed in all white. The sinner’s body was limp, lifeless even.

“Ah, great eye, Taro! That part tells the end of the story.” Moore grew quiet, drawing out the moment. “After the human falls in love with the beautiful angel, he asks to receive a potion that would turn him into an angel. This way he could grow wings and join his lover in eternity.”

Izuku related to the sinner human more than he liked to admit.

He always pictured himself soaked in sin. From his conception to now, every bit of Izuku’s life was tainted with unforgivable darkness. If he’d been given any chance of being normal—of being an *angel*—he would take it.

He would drink that potion too in a heartbeat if it meant his fate would change.

“Wow,” Mina said with a dreamy look. “Changing who you are to fly away with the person you love. So sweet!”

“At this point in the story, yes.” Moore interrupted. He clasped his hands together while his eyes never left the last panel. “Unfortunately, it turned out the angel was an angel of death—not love. The angel was sent to collect the human’s soul for hell but fell in love along the way. So, when the time came, instead of delivering a potion that would turn the human into an angel, he gave him a red apple injected with viper venom. It ends his lover’s life.”

Izuku was saddened.

“The angel weeps because he did truly love the human,” Moore continued. “However, nothing could be done as he watched all the life drain from his lover’s face. The human spends eternity in hell. Then the story ends there.”

How bleek.

Izuku restrained himself from giving Moore a dirty look. This felt like a looming threat.

“That’s...dark,” Kirishima whispered. “I have to admit I thought it would be a happy ending.”

“Seems a little off brand for the whole romantic paradise theme,” Katsuki said suspiciously. “What kind of moral is behind some fucked up shit like that?”

“That sometimes the person you love is also the same reason for your demise,” Moore explained. “We never truly know another person—only what they show us.”

Izuku stared apprehensively at the tempting red apple.

Izuku was enjoying every single Paradise activity with great joy, truthfully. With everything he did, he found himself feeling the slightest bit normal like he really was here on vacation.

But every time he got *too* comfortable—Katsuki was there to fuck it up.

Katsuki could probably drive a monk, a priest, *and* a nun to alcoholism.

At this rate, hell, he might drive Izuku to it. Which is why Izuku was only half shocked when Katsuki *dropped* him to the damn ground in their aerobatics class.

His legs hit the hard surface with a loud, horrible bang. Everyone in the vicinity turned to them with scandalized looks. Izuku whipped his head to glare at Katsuki and ask *what the actual hell*—but Katsuki was marching right out of the class like the sight of Izuku's ass spooked him.

Izuku nursed his throbbing kneecaps that took the blunt end of the fall. And much to his mortification Momo saw the whole thing. She walked up to him once Katsuki was out of the room.

"Are you okay?" Momo asked. She held out a hand to help him up and Izuku took it. "That looked really painful."

"Oh, I'm totally fine." Izuku tried to laugh it off. He winced but smiled through it and waved his hand politely. "It was an accident. Taro had to rush to the bathroom."

Momo frowned. "He could at least have put you down gently."

Yes, Momo. Yes he could have, Izuku mentally agreed.

"He's just tired," Izuku deflected.

Izuku was about to follow after Katsuki but then suddenly, Momo pulled out a card from her pocket. Izuku's face dropped when he saw the bold letters: Licensed Therapist and Mental Health Professional.

Shit.

Momo's credentials could blow his cover if she saw fit to file a domestic abuse allegation against Katsuki. Then that would lead to nosy cops.

"I see a lot of this behavior," Momo said sincerely. "I obviously won't give a diagnosis but if your husband is being emotionally abusive to you, you can tell me."

"Oh! H-He's not abusive!" Izuku rushed to deny it. He shook his head furiously but Momo didn't seem convinced. "Really it was an accident—"

"—Well if that's the case, maybe some couples' counseling might be good?" Momo said. She tilted her head and looked down at his reddened knee caps. "Even if that was an accident, the

lack of care he has for you after dropping you to the ground is worrisome. Not to mention how he undermines you during our meals. It's very notable that he doesn't treat you well. The Ashido-Kirishimas have noticed it as well."

Izuku nearly saw red.

Katsuki was going to blow this for him. *Yet again.*

Izuku took Momo's card, excused himself, and calmly walked off. Once he was in the locker room, he checked if anyone was around and was happy to find himself alone with Katsuki.

Immediately, all his fury let loose.

He didn't let up as he drilled into Katsuki. At first Katsuki was defensive, then slowly he seemed like he agreed with Izuku. They both had a lot riding on Peter Moore being six feet under.

"We're supposed to be affectionate," Izuku emphasized during his lecture. "You know—*nicknames* and all that. You can't call me Dumbass, Deku, and Dipshit all day long in front of these people. If you like 'D' names that much, choose something else. Like dumpling—"

"—*Dumpling*?" Katsuki scoffed and gagged like a goddamn drama queen. "Absolutely fucking not."

"Well, I don't care what you choose," Izuku nearly shouted. "Just stop insulting me in front of people when we're supposed to be madly in love! Call me something *nice*!"

"Alright. How about my *darling* dumbass?" Katsuki sarcastically sneered.

"You could stand to drop the 'dumbass' in front of other people."

"Fine. I'll drop the dumbass." Katsuki scowled.

Izuku stiffened when suddenly Katsuki leaned down from his ogreish height to meet him at eye level.

"Does this do it for you, *darling*?" Katsuki whispered in his raspy voice.

Izuku's anger flat lined and his heart fluttered. He found himself faced with the inexplicable need to lean in. The low octave 'darling' was said in spoke to his sleeping desires.

Darling was a nickname Izuku always liked. He thought it was sweet, endearing, and he sometimes fantasized about being given a pet name. And it sounded *perfect* in Katsuki's voice.

Suddenly, a strange pull of tension strung them together.

Katsuki eyes danced down to his lips and lingered a second too long to be written off as platonic. Izuku was well versed in lustful gazes. They crawled all over his body constantly—and Katsuki was currently giving him one.

“Ye-Yeah,” Izuku stammered. “Darling works.”

On cue, weakness hit the back of his knees. They were *way* too close. Izuku took a large step back in an attempt to regain his composure. Like magic, the fluttering in his heart slowed its tempo with the distance.

How did that always happen with Katsuki?

Everything about Katsuki affected Izuku. Whether it be anger, sadness, or *want*, Katsuki always managed to draw emotion out of him.

Izuku knew he needed to keep his distance.

ᔓᔓᔓ

The rest of the day was not an entire disaster. But it was obvious that he and Katsuki weren’t exactly a couple.

Shouto and Inasa were keeping an unusually close eye on them. But after the aerobics class, Momo was too. Every time Katsuki was a little too rough with him, Momo would narrow her eyes as if she was going to whip out her business card and cut Katsuki with it.

They needed to figure out how to come off as a couple fast.

But the mission was making progress regardless of their bumpy start.

By a stroke of luck, that was surely manufactured by Moore, they ran into him again. Their mark came up to them at the lounge bar with his uncanny smile.

But this time he was accompanied by a strange, lanky man that had standoffish vibes. Moore’s companion had long black hair that was slicked back and a sunken face. He was dressed in all black and sitting pretty on his collar was a golden pin of a dove.

His name was revealed to be Koizumi.

Instantly, Izuku immediately recognized the name.

Koizumi was who Inko said offered her a new life and money in exchange for him. He secretly curled his fist behind his back and his fingernails bit into his skin. As Koizumi talked, deep disdain echoed in Izuku.

While hiding his fist, Izuku grinned at both Moore and Koizumi. His smile was real, because all he could imagine was slitting their throats for what they did.

During the conversation, it was easy to pickpocket Moore’s wallet. The faux jolly man didn’t notice when Izuku’s sly hand snuck down during their hug. When Moore and Koizumi were gone, Izuku opened it.

The only thing inside were black business cards. Each card was marked with a single white dove in the middle.

It all strung together. Koizumi and Moore both had White Dove pins. And there was a cruise ship at the dock that had a giant white dove on it too. Izuku knew it was all connected—which meant there was only one place to go.

“Well, it looks like we’ll be going on that cruise boat after all,” Izuku said. “I’ll buy tickets for us to go on it tomorrow.”

Everything was going to get serious from here on out.

ɯɯɯ

When they made it back to their room, the awkwardness from the day was apparent.

If Izuku was a teacher, he’d give Katsuki a double F minus on his performance. Izuku unhappily bought the tickets for the White Dove Love Boat, and they retired for the evening.

Izuku climbed into the heart-shaped bed and watched Katsuki struggle on the couch again. The large man kept tossing and turning. It nearly looked like a cartoon with how tiny the couch was.

His heart pulled for him, despite all the antics.

Leading with his empathic side, Izuku scooted over. He smiled softly and coaxed Katsuki in bed with some effort. Katsuki immediately built a pillow barrier between them and Izuku couldn’t stop himself from laughing at the stupid row of red pillows.

After a small conversation, Izuku stared up at the ceiling.

As he listened to Katsuki’s steady breathing, Izuku thought about his life back home. A lot was riding on the success of this mission.

“Y’know,” Izuku said into the silence. “If you’re going to have trouble pretending to be my husband, this means we’re going to have a tough time convincing Moore we’re in love. Which is going to cause issues for us to gain his trust. Our plan is only going to work if we’re in harmony.”

A whistle from the gust of wind from outside reached Izuku’s ears.

“Teach me,” Katsuki said.

It was so soft that Izuku nearly missed it. He turned to Katsuki to make sure he hadn’t imagined that.

Izuku’s breath hitched at how close they really were.

Katsuki’s eyes were near enough that Izuku could make out various shades of red. Layers of hues were stacked up on top of each other. Scarlet. Amber. Even a touch of blood orange twinkled from underneath.

For once, the red eyes that always stopped Izuku's heart weren't full of hatred. Instead they were silently pleading with him. It was as if Katsuki was lost at sea and Izuku was the only raft in sight.

"Er, for this assignment," Katsuki elaborated. "You clearly know how to mimic all this lovey dovey bullshit to the last bat of an eyelash. So, show me how to play the dumb part of a doting husband until we finish off that bastard."

Izuku's heart clutched dangerously once more when the unspoken tension between them returned. Katsuki's gaze flickered all over. His hair, his cheeks, it was like the man was unconsciously counting his freckles and it sent unusual feelings into Izuku.

Izuku swallowed thickly as he treaded carefully.

"Are you sure, Katsuki?"

"Yeah. Teach me how to be in love, Izuku."

Izuku knew he was damned from that moment on.

ɯɯɯ

Third Day in Paradise

Izuku was nervous yet *excited.*

Teaching Katsuki about love was going to allow him to put himself to the ultimate test.

That morning after getting dressed, Izuku thumbed through his novel. He was trying to find any passages that would be a good starting point.

He found sixty seven.

This truly was shaping up to be a vacation. Izuku began writing a bunch of notes: The hand holding. The longing stares. The eagerness to see one's lover. Anticipating each other's needs. It was fun to piece together the concept of romance as a lesson plan.

Izuku smiled as he looked at what he'd written.

Kacchan had no clue what type of obsession he created that day in the nook—but Izuku was so thankful for it.

As he placed one more neon-colored tab on a page, a droplet of self doubt nested in his head. He paused as he considered a very large glaring fact: he had no clue what real romance was like. Could he really teach another about it if he never experienced it himself?

Izuku nervously fiddled with the page of his novel as he thought about this.

When they made it onto The White Dove Love Boat Izuku's heart nearly bursted at the seams.

The whole cruise boat was a setting straight out of a movie.

The boat was painted a sophisticated cream color, trimmed in gold and had mahogany flooring. Dipping down from the top deck to the bottom like ribbons were endless rows of romantic white fairy lights that perfectly illuminated all the waiters below. Each waiter smiled with golden platters in their hands ready to serve pink martinis.

Izuku's eyes lit up like fireworks when he saw the long beach chairs next to the railing. But even better, there was a *band*.

He gazed at the couples dancing joyfully in front of the band.

Beside him, Katsuki groaned. "For fucks' sake. This is—"

"—Nice!" Izuku finished happily. Immediately he dragged the grouch by his arm. "Hurry! Let's stake our claim on one of the chairs next to the band."

Izuku was happy to find Katsuki didn't put up much of a fight. He was getting more receptive to their fake husbands ploy.

Maybe by the end of the week they would finally be convincing husbands.

Izuku immediately started his lesson plan. He told Katsuki which passage to read and could visibly see Katsuki swallow his pride. They sat on the desk quietly side by side holding hands as Katsuki read.

Izuku turned his head to watch the couples dance.

Each pair was moving to their own unique synchronization. It was like they knew the other person from the inside out. There was a young couple who were happily giggling and spinning each other. Next to them was an older couple with ashen gray hairs. They moved slowly as their fingers intertwined and their foreheads rested against each other.

Izuku tried to imagine himself with someone like that.

He attempted to picture Chisaki at first. The Yakuza Heir wasn't exactly ugly. His aura was like a dark prince of the underworld that took very good care of his captives. Izuku sucked his teeth at this thought. Maybe accepting his future doom would be good—but the imagery fell apart at the seams.

Next, Izuku tried to imagine himself and Kacchan. But Kacchan was so mentally far away and potentially dead.

Without even trying, Izuku perfectly pictured him and Katsuki.

He surprised himself a bit. He could easily imagine them dancing in each other's arms in a slow, deadly waltz of their own. A fiery push and pull of need and hate. Of softness and brute force. Izuku's core tightened at the thought of being in Katsuki's arms and having his fingers rake down his spine.

Izuku's thoughts dangerously went astray. What would it be like to kiss Katsuki?

Then suddenly gentle lips connected with his hand.

Caught off guard, Izuku whipped his head so fast he nearly broke his neck. Katsuki's lips were pressed directly against the top of his hand. The gesture shot longing right into Izuku's veins. Katsuki's burning eyes snapped up to look at him and stole all of Izuku's breath.

"What are you doing?" Izuku asked tightly.

"What does it look like, idiot? I'm kissing your hand," Katsuki said as though it was obvious. He held up the book for context. "That's what they did on page twenty. Seems a little fast to me, but that's a normal affectionate thing between pining husbands. Right?"

Of course. The book. He had forgotten and got lost in his thoughts that fast.

"Oh. Ye-Yeah," Izuku said. He awkwardly readjusted his sun hat. "Um, good job. Keep reading."

It was then Izuku knew his unfortunate crush sprung back to life.

He tried to will away the picture of him and Katsuki dancing and kissing.

He was unsuccessful.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku was thankful Inasa and Shouto found them before his mind could wander further.

The Todoroki husbands invited them to join them in the cooking class in the lower basement. Izuku happily agreed to it. He was always kept on a strict diet and because of that, Izuku eagerly took any chance to try forbidden foods or fruits when Tomura wasn't around.

It was supposed to be a cute and easy baking class.

It was *supposed* to be light and fun. But of course—Katsuki made it absolutely *impossible*. It was bad enough that Izuku struggled to keep his thoughts clean. But the entire baking class Katsuki kept his sleeves rolled up and teased him. With every kneed into the dough, Izuku saw how Katsuki's ridiculous muscles flexed and rippled.

And damn—he had *arms*.

Katsuki was ripped to the heavens and back. Like he did arm day seven days a week and also in his sleep. Izuku tried to keep his eyes on his own dough. But it was *impossible* with that Herculean distraction directly next to him.

But that wasn't the icing on the doughnut. *Oh no.*

Katsuki turned everything into filthy temptation within mere minutes.

“These are nothing but metaphorical creampies in pastry form.”

Izuku regretted not packing duck tape. He should’ve packed a whole suitcase full so he could keep Katsuki’s mouth *shut*.

“Stop being so crude,” Izuku harshly snapped back. “People can hear you so don’t say that.”

“What? Don’t say *creampie*?” Katsuki said louder. “That’s exactly what the hell these are—”

Izuku wearily glanced around at the people who heard. Several couples were looking at them like they were perverts. An elderly woman shook her head and Izuku was overcome with embarrassment.

“—Now once you get the hole all adjusted, it’s ready to be filled to the brim!” The instructor said gleefully. “Just insert the tip of the piping bag when giving the hole the custard. Nothing more. You don’t want to stretch your hole too wide.”

Izuku grew quiet at that. His cheeks burned as he tried to fill up the doughnut. Heat simmered at the bottom of his belly as he unwillingly imagined the doughnut in his hand as something else.

Katsuki flashed a mirthful smirk and Izuku wanted to slap him.

“C’mon, nerd. Fucking look at ‘em.” Katsuki chuckled darkly and leaned into his personal space. Izuku’s heart hammered harder. “You really don’t see it?”

“No. I don’t.”

Izuku glared at Katsuki despite the slow rising heat in his core. He turned to quickly get this task done without incident. But then Katsuki took one of the freshly filled pastries and held it up to his lips.

Izuku began to protest—but it was too late.

Without breaking eye contact, Katsuki dragged his tongue up the soft pastry, lapping up the drizzle of white custard that oozed out. He swirled his tongue around the brim a bit, and Izuku’s eyes widened at the expertise of the gesture.

Then Izuku gasped in horror as Katsuki sunk his tongue into the pastry.

This man was an absolute *slut*.

All it took was one flick of Katsuki’s tongue to make Izuku imagine Katsuki doing that to him.

Suddenly, the piping bag in Izuku’s hands burst.

Custard went everywhere. In his nose. In his hair. Izuku yelled in surprise when his whole face was suddenly covered in thick cream. He scattered to wipe it off, and quickly realized it was his fault. He didn’t even know he’d been squeezing the bag that tightly.

It was awful how the filthy imagery didn't leave his mind right away. It lingered. The picture of Katsuki eating out a very different creampie slowly burned its way through Izuku's overactive imagination.

Izuku ran straight for the bathroom.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Fury, embarrassment and arousal swirled in Izuku. He looked at himself in the bathroom mirror after he washed off all the custard. His hair was dripping wet and his cheeks were pink as can be. He took a deep, shaky breath in.

He squeezed his eyes shut, and tried to wash away any dirty scenarios involving Katsuki's skillful tongue. But he was wildly unsuccessful. He saw Katsuki caressing him, kissing him, and undressing him.

It was like Taiwan all over again when Izuku couldn't stop himself from getting bricked up.

Izuku placed his hand on his beating heart in a plea and squeezed his eyes shut.

Please. Please stop.

It took twenty full minutes for Izuku to calm down.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When the boat finally docked, he and Katsuki went straight to business. They were able to locate the White Dove Headquarters quickly. The gray warehouse was completely isolated and almost fully underground. It had the stamp of a white dove with an olive branch on the side.

Chilling aura was all around the woods. In the distance, the sneaky crunch of footsteps could be heard trailing in front of them. Izuku and Katsuki took an offensive stance, ready to strike.

Izuku thought it would be some of Moore's henchmen—but he was wrong.

To his surprise, it was the Todoroki husbands.

And then they learned the two were *cops*.

Fate was a cruel person, Izuku thought. Not only was he settled with a fake husband who could *barely* play the part, now there were two cops in his Paradise group watching his every move. Both him and Katsuki took a break to call their supervisors.

Izuku fiddled with his phone a bit, practicing what he could say to buy himself more time. He pressed the contact '117' but Tomura did not pick up. Izuku frowned a bit.

He then dialed the direct link for The Academy and was greeted by Aoyama's cheery voice.

“Hello!” Aoyama said. “You’ve reached The Viper Academy. Is there anything I can help you with?”

“Hi Aoyama. It’s me. Is Tomura there?” Izuku asked. “I need to talk to him about this Moore assignment.”

“No, he’s abroad with One right now,” Aoyama said. “They were actually supposed to be back today but apparently need to lay low longer. Someone from One’s past apparently caught wind of him being in Czechia.”

Izuku pursed his lips. Just his luck—but this could work.

“I know this was supposed to be a quick assignment but, there’s cops here. They’re directly next to me and I don’t want to risk them outting me. Do you think you can add on extra time? This assignment is more complicated than I thought.”

Izuku looked over his shoulder at Katsuki in the distance.

“Cops? Shit,” Aoyama muttered. Izuku could hear the rapid click clack of the board. “Okay. I added extra time to the assignment with a red flag of cops close by. When One and Tomura come back, I’ll let them know what happened and I’m sure they’ll understand. In the meantime, lay as low as possible until we get word on what One wants to do.”

Izuku nodded. “Great, I’ll see you soon. Tell Katsuma goodnight for me.”

“Haha of course! I tell him every day. He misses you.”

Izuku softly smiled at that.

In a twist of events, he got just what he wanted: more time.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When they regrouped, something in Katsuki shifted.

His shoulders were relaxed. His body language was leisure and the edge in his eyes was gone. He looked at Izuku now like he wasn’t the worst person in the world—maybe only the second.

Katsuki told Izuku his supervisor didn’t answer the phone. But he seemed okay with it. He had to wait until he got instructions on what to do, and Izuku told him the same.

Now, they really were on vacation.

They walked the beach side by side quietly. A few idle words were exchanged until they finally came to a halt. They had time to kill before the cruise came back and overall, Izuku was happy.

They sat on the beach chatting and going over more lessons in love. This time Izuku felt a bit more confident in explaining and Katsuki was more open to accepting the information. They

were getting there—slowly but surely.

As they ate the pastries on the beach, Izuku watched the sunset. Katsuki stopped reading and did the same.

Everything halted in time as the beautiful orange and red colors kissed the earth. The reflection against the deep blue sea was like a painting being breathed to life in front of them.

“I love watching sunsets like this,” Katsuki suddenly said.

Izuku turned to him and his heart leaped. The reflection of the rosy hues painted across Katsuki’s skin, lips, and eyes. He was haloed in a light of beauty that was captivating. Without taking his eyes off the sunset, Katsuki genuinely smiled for the first time Izuku ever saw.

It suited him.

“Is there a reason you love sunsets so much?” Izuku asked.

“It reminds me I’m human.” Katsuki turned to him. “We’re all just humans under the same sky.”

The weight of the words sat on Izuku’s mind as the colors bled from the sky.

They boarded the boat to the mainland that evening under beautiful stars. Everything was shining brightly as fate took her time aligning the constellations. Izuku admired the night sky while they were on the boat.

But then his peace was broken.

Peter Moore joined their boat ride back to the mainland. But there was an unsettling gleam in his eyes. He surveyed Izuku in a way that Izuku knew all too well: like he was property. His eerie gaze was a mirror of Nine, Chisaki, and Tomura wrapped up in one.

It unsettled Izuku when he was given a white lei.

Moore carefully tucked an olive branch behind his ear and Izuku’s heart dropped straight into his stomach. He suddenly felt like he had slipped off his balancing beam. He was struck with the reality he was nothing more than property once more.

Then Katsuki did something to save him from his own neuroticism.

“Thanks for the leis, but I promised my husband a dance before you all came over,” Katsuki said suddenly. “I want to make sure we have enough time to dance before the boat docks.”

He smiled at Izuku and extended his hand out.

“Are you ready, darling?” Katsuki asked, gazing at Izuku expectantly.

It was a vision: Katsuki sat across from him with his lopsided grin under the fairy lights. His eyes were pouring protectiveness and they looked at him and only him. Izuku grabbed Katsuki’s hand and instantly Katsuki intertwined their fingers. Izuku was swept away from that dark side of his mind and Moore.

A bit of Izuku wished this wasn’t fake. But with the eyes of Moore and the Todorokis he knew Katsuki was trying his best to act.

But as the night bled on, some type of line blurred. It didn’t feel exactly fake when Katsuki defended his song choice to the band and it didn’t feel entirely fake as they slowly danced together.

Both Moore and the Todorokis were long elsewhere, but the two of them stayed rooted under the stars.

Katsuki held him gently as they swayed back and forth in sync with the ocean. They held eye contact as they laughed and Izuku’s heart melted right into the center of Katsuki’s gravity. The breeze blew through Katsuki’s hair and ruffled the red lei around his neck.

He tried to remind himself that they were acting. But then Katsuki lifted a hand to brush his bangs out of his face. The touch was electrifying as Izuku leaned in closer. Katsuki didn’t notice.

“I guess this boat ain’t that bad,” Katsuki muttered. He winked playfully. “You have good taste.”

Katsuki smiled down at Izuku and his heart soared high.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Fourth Day in Paradise

The next morning came and Moore invited them out into the Yanburu woods. Magically, they had won a *randomized* lottery for a free camping trip add on. How totally not suspicious.

Before the mission, Izuku was instructed by Aoyama to steer clear of the Yanbaru forest. There was no cell phone signal on that part of the island and Izuku needed to be accessible at all moments.

But it seemed like Moore knew that. He was going to isolate their Paradise Crew for something sinister.

It was odd that Izuku hadn’t heard back from Tomura yet. Usually Tomura answered his calls on the first ring, like a responsible elder brother and handler. But this was the first time in history Izuku was left hanging for more than two hours.

Whatever was happening in Czechia must’ve been chaotic.

Izuku only hoped Tomura called back before he lost signal because he was the only one given white colored camping gear.

Laying low wouldn't be an option for long. Izuku wasn't stupid.

He knew white was a signal to traffic him. Whoever worked for Moore would see Izuku's white colored backpack and know he was next for their trafficking rings. Izuku's suspicions were confirmed when they walked out into the lobby. The feeling of prickling eyes pierced into his nape like needles. He glanced around to see all the workers staring at him.

Sadness embraced Izuku.

He really was destined to be property, wasn't he?

Even in a resort, with at least a *thousand* other people, Moore still managed to single him out. Maybe there was something about him that made him seem like an easy target.

Izuku blamed his freckles. He wished he could rip each one from his skin one by one.

ᔓᔓᔓ

His suspicions were bitterly confirmed when later that day someone tried to kidnap him.

They had gotten stuck in the woods due to a prank by their Paradise Crew. Their group left him and Katsuki stranded by the lake without their clothes in a poor attempt to make them bond. It was surely supposed to be harmless since it wasn't forecasted to rain.

But of course, with Izuku's luck, it rained.

His would-be-kidnapper tried to slit Katsuki's throat but Katsuki easily dodged. Izuku quickly went on the offensive and disarmed the assailant. It took less than a minute for them to overpower the attacker. It was the first time they worked in sync rather than against each other. It was surprising how fluid they moved side by side—an unstoppable duo.

When Katsuki snapped the man's neck Izuku forced himself to feel nothing.

But curiously, he witnessed Katsuki's shoulders sag. His eyes glazed over slightly, and it was clear he was affected by it. This was the first time Izuku saw someone in their line of work be *sad* for the loss of life.

It was odd. Weren't they supposed to be immune to it? Izuku always thought feeling sadness was wrong and he demonized himself every time he felt sorry for killing.

They found shelter in a cave through the storm. While inside, Izuku couldn't contain his curiosity about what triggered Katsuki's solemn expression.

"Do you...Do you feel anything when you do it?" Izuku asked, barely above a whisper.

Katsuki was leaning against the cave wall in nothing but his boxers. His muscles were rigid and his expression was apprehensive. He stared at Izuku with vulnerability he never gave

before.

“Most days I don’t,” Katsuki answered honestly. He hung his head and shrugged his shoulders. “But more recently—yeah. I do.”

Katsuki didn’t know it, but he shifted Izuku’s world view with those single words.

It was like everything Izuku knew about emotions shifted ever so slightly off its axis.

“I feel a little bit too,” Izuku nervously admitted. “I try my best not to, like I was trained. But it’s something about when the moment comes to finish—the inkling of the subconscious I try to drown speaks out.”

It was like a weight off his chest had been lifted up. This was the first time he openly admitted to his weaknesses without judgment. Katsuki’s eyes softened. He looked at Izuku like they were kindred spirits and it made Izuku’s heart warm with tiny comfort.

It was then Izuku considered maybe he wasn’t as weak as he thought.

“A mark is a mark,” Katsuki said quietly. “Subconscious or not, we have a job to do. Loose ends aren’t good. Especially ones that are trying to traffic you.”

Izuku couldn’t stop the dry, sarcastic laugh that he let out.

If only Katsuki knew the irony in that statement. Moore already successfully trafficked him.

“Yeah,” Izuku whispered. “I guess not.”

Later that night, Katsuki graciously offered up his body heat. Izuku rejected it at first. But then he allowed himself to once again be reminded by Katsuki that he was only human.

He was a human who was affected by small things like the weather and moved to tears by larger things like loss of life. He curled up underneath Katsuki that night and allowed himself to *be* for the first time.

Katsuki wrapped his arms around him and the full bare-body skin on skin contact shocked Izuku. It threw him off at first, and he had to adjust to it in the same way someone would feel getting into hot bathwater.

But slowly, Izuku relaxed into Katsuki. This close, he could smell Katsuki’s natural cinnamon musk mixed in with the scent of rain.

The unnamed tension returned as they slotted together.

Katsuki’s hand wordlessly fiddled with the hem of his lace underwear and Izuku didn’t say anything about it. It was a curious touch, like Katsuki was trying to piece together Izuku.

The lingering fingers made Izuku’s core tighten strangely and he tried to stay as still as a statue.

Half way through the night, Izuku heard Katsuki's snoring. He turned around carefully and studied Katsuki up close. He looked so peaceful sleeping, and Izuku noted Katsuki's dark blond eyelashes. With tender care, Izuku traced Katsuki's cheekbones and his fingers lingered at his lips.

Katsuki roused closer in his sleep at the touch. Their chests pressed together and their beating hearts locked in sync.

"Thank you for reminding me, I'm human," Izuku whispered.

He wrapped his arms around Katsuki and fell asleep peacefully.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Fifth Day in Paradise

When the next morning came, their Paradise Crew found them rather easily. They showered them with apologies and Izuku quickly forgave them. He knew they had no ill intent and it wasn't the worst thing in the world to get stuck with Katsuki in a cave.

Five days ago he might've thought differently but now—now he is growing more fond of Katsuki than he thought was possible.

Katsuki was soft. He was rough. He was an asshole but he was caring at the same time. He was a mess of conflicting characters but that's what made him what he was: human. He didn't need to flatten himself out to be one thing or the other. He could be multiple things at once without it having it beaten out of him like Izuku.

For the first time, Izuku gave himself grace with his lack of control over his emotions.

He got slightly lost in his thoughts as he struggled with the notion of if he was a real viper. Maybe he wasn't? Real vipers only felt anger, greed, pride, and bloodlust. Izuku felt so many other things like empathy, love, and sympathy.

Maybe he was supposed to run away with Kacchan and live an entirely different life.

Maybe the path he was on now wasn't his true fate.

But, in order for that to be true, Kacchan would still have to be alive. And Izuku couldn't torture himself with thoughts of maybe or ifs. Instead he looked at who was in front of him now: Katsuki.

Currently Katsuki was rowing a canoe down a small stream with both of them inside of it.

It was a miracle that Katsuki was being so tame now. He was eager to learn the next lesson in love and it made Izuku's heart swell with joy a bit. Katsuki was rough around the edges but soft in the middle and it was endearing.

They settled in that night around the campfire with the rest of their Paradise Crew.

But more exciting, he got to make *s'mores* for the first time in his life! Katsuki graciously helped him, holding his hand over Izuku's. Katsuki smiled at his naivety and Izuku didn't feel embarrassed. He let himself be helped like a normal human and couldn't stop from leaning against Katsuki.

When he bit into the messy treat, Izuku hummed happily. He forgot where he was and enjoyed the moment. He was totally making these for Katsuma when he got home.

Then softly, Katsuki reached forward and wiped his mouth for him.

"You always make such a fucking mess," Katsuki mumbled.

His fake husband made sure he was marshmallow free and intertwined their fingers together. It was done with ease and it was beginning to feel comfortable. Izuku shyly smiled. Katsuki was so kind and their hands fit together so well.

Their Paradise crew fell into an interesting conversation about life. Then it segued into telling interesting facts about one another. Everyone shared something about themselves that was unique, and Izuku was loving it.

"I was switched at birth," Momo shared first. "I ended up finding my real parents in my teens, so I have two sets of parents now."

How lucky, Izuku thought. Double the love.

"I stole my first electric guitar," Jirou admitted. She earned a judgmental glare from Shouto.

"I'm from a long line of farmers," Inasa said. "I came to the city once in college and liked it so much that I moved to a big city."

"Oh!" Eijirou spoke up. "I have black hair naturally, but I dye it."

Everyone was so flawed—no. Everyone was *human*.

Izuku felt inclined to share. He nervously squeezed Katsuki's hand to get some bravery.

"I...I overcame a small lisp when I was younger," Izuku confessed in a small voice. "I had selective mutism as a child, so I ended up being a bit late on my speech development."

Everyone hummed and nodded. Jirou told him he shouldn't feel ashamed. It was common. Izuku's heart melted in a comfort he never knew. This whole time—he wasn't defected, he was merely a human with human flaws.

Next was Katsuki's turn.

At first, it wasn't something that shocked Izuku.

"I have lucid dreams," Katsuki admitted. "So I, uh, wake up feeling like I slept a long time but I don't feel well rested."

Then slowly, Katsuki's speech transformed into something increasingly confusing.

"I...I dream about this boy I knew when I was younger," Katsuki further added.

Momo put her therapist hat on as she pulled more and more information from him.

"We spent a full year together from the ages seven to eight," Katsuki confessed.

Izuku saw Kacchan in the nook holding his hand.

"She had left me in the streets to fend for myself."

Izuku saw Kacchan crying for his mother.

"I was wandering around worried about her while I nearly fucking died of *hypothermia*."

Izuku saw Kacchan shivering in the cold with no jacket.

With each detail, an irrational scenario was pieced together. But it was supposed to be *impossible*. Izuku's eyes widened with every word. San'ya. Blond hair. Red eyes. Lost at seven. Found at eight. Abandoned in the winter. No. No. No. There wasn't any statistical way this could be *true*.

Izuku couldn't believe it—

—Until the final blow landed.

"He couldn't even pronounce my name—had to call me 'Kacchan.' Some days it felt like he was the only person to ever love me, and I never saw him after that."

Everything stood still and the woods faded away underneath the words.

They were floating in darkness with nothing but the bright flame of the fire beside them. In slow motion, all the years passed by. From the moment they were younger to the present. Every beautiful version of Katsuki flashed before him like a flip book. They all turned to face him and smiled.

"Well, besides Hiroji," Momo suddenly said, snapping Izuku out of his mind.

"What?" Katsuki frowned and gave her a confused stare.

"Hiroji loves you," Momo repeated. She gestured to Izuku with a genuine smile. "You two are married."

Uncontrollable tears welled up in Izuku's eyes.

He blinked rapidly, unable to take his eyes off Katsuki. He tried to memorize every spike, every wrinkle, every frown line and refined curve of his face. He overlapped the boy he used to know with the man in front of him and it was a perfect alignment.

"Right. Yeah." Katsuki suddenly let go of his hand but Izuku couldn't move. "Of course."

“I think remembering that boy will help you,” Momo suggested. She clasped her hands and nodded happily. “You should allow yourself to reflect on that year and stop suppressing it so deeply. This way when you do feel like there are days that no one loves you, you can remember what he did—and lean on your partner for support. You love and care for Taro, don’t you Hiroji?”

Katsuki cut his eyes to him.

The first thing Izuku wanted to blurt out is that *he* was the boy.

But his tongue stayed still under all the eyes on them.

“Ye—Yeah. I-I d-do,” Izuku breathlessly whispered. His eyes searched Katsuki’s features, studying them meticulously. He blinked back his tears as he said words that were straight from the heart. “I lo-love and care about him a lot.”

Katsuki’s face soured at the mention of ‘love’. It was like the word was poison and curdled his blood. The air shifted—but Izuku didn’t know why. Katsuki grew so quiet and his nose scrunched in the same way it did when they were kids.

“I’m going to go look at the stars or whatever,” Katsuki muttered.

He stood up to leave without sparing a single person a glance. Izuku’s eyes stayed glued to him with every step.

“I…I’m going to go follow him,” Izuku whispered shakily. “T-To make sure he’s okay.”

Izuku stood up and followed the pull in his heart.

ɯɯɯ

Izuku found Katsuki sitting alone on the edge of a cliff close to the campsite. He was sitting down on a moss covered tree, facing the open sky. His head was lowered between his shoulders and on top of his back looked like the weight of the world.

Izuku purposefully stepped on a twig and snapped it to give Katsuki a heads up he was coming. It worked easily and Katsuki turned around. His glare was in full force and the expression on his face read: leave me the fuck alone.

But Izuku couldn’t.

Never again could he leave Katsuki alone.

“Came to check up on your husband?” Katsuki asked sarcastically. He tore a green leaf in his hands in two aggressively with a sneer. “You know, you don’t have to be attached to my ass all the time.”

Izuku didn’t respond.

He assessed Katsuki's mood and knew he was deeply upset. It probably was about Momo forcing vulnerability out of him in front of strangers, and Izuku felt sorry for him.

He took a seat next to Katsuki on the tree root. Izuku couldn't peel his eyes away from Katsuki.

He'd grown used to seeing ghosts. He saw Sen. He saw Hiryu. He saw the people he killed. Izuku even saw Kacchan's ghost—but this whole time the phantom from his childhood was really the steady stranger in his life.

Izuku had to give it up to Fate.

She was creative in her plans. Every step of the way Izuku thought Katsuki was a curse. But now the sheer sight of him tugged on every heart string Izuku had until they snapped.

"I wonder if certain things are written in the stars," Izuku whispered with a blue undertone.

He forcefully turned his eyes up to the sky as he tried to think of what to say. But he wasn't any good at this. Too many phrases cluttered his thoughts and he had not a clue how to begin to say, 'it's me. I'm the boy you've been thinking of for years. And I've been thinking of you too. Now what?'

Instead, Izuku tried a more graceful approach and asked, "Do you believe in fate, Katsuki?"

"No," Katsuki answered. He shredded another leaf. "Fate doesn't exist."

Izuku's heart clutched. "Why do you think that?"

"Because the only thing that's real is the consequences for your actions," Katsuki said bluntly. "We all have free will over our decisions and blaming fate on the outcome is an easy scapegoat. But I'm guessing *you* believe in fate."

"It depends," Izuku's small voice said. "Usually I don't, but sometimes it's hard to ignore the signs."

Izuku glanced down to their wedding bands trying to find the words.

"D-Do you believe it's possible for two people to be meant to be in each other's lives?" Izuku blurted out. He timidly scooted over on the root, closer to Katsuki. His eyes shyly looked down at Katsuki's hand and he yearned to reach for it. "For example, let's say, if they were forcefully separated the first time, fate would bring them back together...yeah?"

Izuku reached out to hold Katsuki's hand—

—and Katsuki coldly shifted away.

Izuku's hand grasped nothing. It hurt like a twisted knife in the heart. Izuku swiftly retracted his hand, suddenly feeling stupid. That simple gesture reminded him that Katsuki did not like *Deku*. Katsuki was merely tolerating him and all the fake niceness from the last five days was just that: fake. Not real.

“Izuku. I don’t really care about this romantic shit right now—”

“—It’s not romantic,” Izuku corrected.

He hung his head to hide his hurt. It was then Izuku knew there was one of two reactions Katsuki could have to Izuku revealing it was him: Katsuki would either be shocked and relieved. Or disgusted to know it was him.

‘Fucking freak’ echoed in Izuku’s ears.

Carefully, he probed Katsuki to gauge what his reaction might be.

“I-I’m just talking,” Izuku said. “I wanted to know how you would feel about possibly having...a person you were meant to cross paths with.”

Katsuki scoffed.

“It sounds over optimistic,” Katsuki cut down unkindly. “I don’t believe two people are destined to meet each other. Fate doesn’t bring them together because fate isn’t *real*. No one on this dumb earth is destined to meet anyone. The only thing we’re destined for is death.”

Izuku sucked at his teeth.

He absorbed the words and concluded what Katsuki’s reaction would be. It would be violent disgust and he probably wouldn’t believe it was him. Katsuki undoubtedly kept a pure, lovely version of Izuku in his head from their childhood. The halo was probably bright and contrasted with *Deku*.

Izuku dolefully studied his hands.

Katsuki would be mortified to know what he had grown into: a viper with a kill count in the thousands. Izuku decided then his final act of kindness for Kacchan would be to shield him. Katsuki never had to know the boy who saved him grew up to be the man he loathed.

Then, they both glanced up once more at the night sky.

At that exact moment two shooting stars fell in tandem.

The sparkling white lights shot across the atmosphere. The trail behind them added more splendor to the already decorated sky. Izuku watched as the twin stars fell in sync, intertwining in a way that crossed their paths among the glittering constellations.

Katsuki turned to Izuku with his beautiful red eyes. He quietly asked, “What did you wish for?”

Izuku smiled sadly. “I have nothing to wish for anymore. My one wish has already come true.”

Fate finally brought him back the one person he always wished to see. He looked down at the ruby wedding ring on his hand in a new light and was thankful he was able to keep the

promise he made.

“Now we’re husbands and you always have to come back to me. Alright? You gotta promise.”

“Okay, Kacchan. I’ll always come back. I promise.”

Chapter End Notes

Thank you so much for reading!! Please give the songs in this chapter a look-see if you have the chance. I've been itching to use them :') I got a whole playlist of songs ready to fire off that tie to so many specific scenes.

Let me know what you think below! Thank you so much for reading and commenting ^_^ 💜

Chapter 23: Espressivo

Chapter Summary

Espressivo (stylistic indicator) to play with expression.

Chapter Notes

Helloooo and welcome back!!! First, big thank you to my power house of a beta and LOML Luna! This chapter was really fun to write and it's been a joy getting to this re-cap arc! Without further delay, I hope you enjoy this chapter and the songs! ^^

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 23 — Espressivo

.

.

.

All the repressed emotions in Izuku grew bigger and bigger until he tore at the seams.

It happened all at once. Joy was amplified. Relief was overwhelming. And finally, sadness was potent against his tongue. He couldn't contain any of the overpowering feelings that poured from his heart.

Somehow, Kacchan was *alive,* and he'd been with him the whole *time*.

They retired for the night to their tent in the woods without many words. Katsuki rolled over on his side and faced away from him.

Izuku stayed still, staring at Katsuki's back all night.

He studied Katsuki's broad shoulders and his thick hair. His large physique contrasted everything Izuku remembered about Kacchan. Back then, Katsuki used to be frail from malnutrition and layers of neglect. He had long, but skinny limbs, sunken eyes, and thinning hair.

For peace of mind, Izuku concluded that Kacchan got lost in the winter that year. It made sense if his weak body collapsed. Maybe the snow covered him up and no one found his body

until late spring.

That was the tragic end to the boy in the nook.

But somehow, Kacchan not only survived but he survived to be *healthy*.

Izuku smiled solemnly to himself.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Sixth Day in Paradise

When the morning came, Izuku was exhausted. He hadn't slept a wink. He was so terrified that if he closed his eyes Katsuki would vanish.

Since he decided not to sleep, he kept himself busy.

With delicate care, Izuku folded all of Katsuki's clothes. He tucked them in his duffle bag and his fingers lingered on each fabric. He was still amazed at just how *big* Kacchan grew to be.

Izuku folded his own clothes next and then climbed out of the tent. He walked around aimlessly listening to the sounds of the forest. Izuku stopped walking when he came to the river bend. He sat down in the grass and stared at his reflection in the water.

He attempted to mesh together the two versions of himself that Katsuki knew: his younger self and Deku.

They didn't blend—and because of that Izuku was hesitant to tell Katsuki.

By the time Katsuki woke up everyone else was awake too.

Katsuki quipped something sarcastic, but Izuku was too tired to banter. Izuku offered up sheepish smiles instead because that's all he could muster.

Their Paradise Crew packed up the bubblegum pink van with glee. They all piled up in the car to head back to the hotel while laughing and giggling. Izuku took his seat on Katsuki's lap without much fuss. He still felt outside of his body as he slowly absorbed the information of Katsuki being Kacchan.

During the beginning of the car ride Izuku drifted off slowly. He uncomfortably staggered in and out of sleep the longer they drove.

Suddenly, Katsuki leaned forward and whispered in his ear.

"Hey, are you okay?" Katsuki asked in a deeply concerned tone. "You've been quiet. Usually, you're annoying the shit out of me by now."

Izuku stiffened a bit. He twisted slightly to peer behind him.

All he could see now was Kacchan when he gazed at Katsuki.

“Sorry,” Izuku replied quietly. His eyes skirted downwards. “I…I didn’t get any sleep last night. I think I was too on edge and it’s finally catching up to me.”

Katsuki pursed his lips, and then the van hit another bump. They both lurched forward and Izuku deeply exhaled from feeling absolutely beat.

“Lean back,” Katsuki commanded. “You’re not going to get any rest hunched over like that.”

Katsuki leaned backwards and patted his stomach to emphasize his point.

Izuku shook his head and said, “No, it’s okay—”

“—C’mon,” Katsuki said with an annoyed inflection. “Lean back. I’ll steady you while you nap. Ain’t an issue after fucking cuddling damn near nude in your little panties. Nothing can be more embarrassing than that.”

Izuku felt mortified at the mention of his private garments. But he was further forced into embarrassment when Katsuki gripped his shoulders.

It was terrible how well his large hands fit on him. They were the perfect size and warmed that whole area of his skin. Izuku reluctantly allowed himself to be pulled backwards against Katsuki’s sturdy chest.

Katsuki shifted their bodies until they slotted together perfectly.

If he wasn’t so tired, Izuku would be blushing. But the warmth of Katsuki’s body lulled him into a safety he had not felt since the nook. He turned inwards to lean into the crook of Katsuki’s neck. At this angle, he could smell Katsuki’s natural cinnamon musk so clearly.

His mind slipped away into sleep the same moment he looked up. He saw double vision.

Both young and older Katsuki smiled at him.

“You’re…here,” Izuku muttered, finally accepting the truth. “I’m glad you’re here.”

He drifted off into a comfortable sleep as Katsuki wrapped his arms around him.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When they came back to the hotel, it was unsettling. Some of the workers in the lobby were surprised to see him. They did a double take and quickly shuffled away. Izuku ignored them but knew it was something to deal with later.

Katsuki and Izuku said their goodbyes to their Paradise Crew with hugs and fake smiles. When it was only the two of them in the lobby, they reluctantly reached for their cell phones.

Izuku grimaced deeply and Katsuki winced.

15 unread text messages and 10 missed calls glared at him. Most of it was from Tomura. Others were from Aoyama.

Izuku clicked on Aoyama's text first.

[215]: You're still good on the mission. One said take your time, don't leave without killing Moore and steer clear of the cops.

[215]: Also, you need to contact Tomura back right away. He's been on edge. I haven't seen him this pissed in a while.

Izuku reluctantly clicked on Tomura's text.

[117]: Izuku. I forwarded you an email Chisaki sent me so you can understand how livid he is.

[117]: Chisaki is demanding we set a date for the consummation when you come back.

Izuku wearily clicked on his email app. He was mortified to see the email Chisaki sent Tomura was entitled '*Regarding my purchase: Izuku*'.

Chisaki's clipped tone in the email was beyond livid, really. He was egregiously agitated that Izuku left for an assignment right after their deal had been brokered. Apparently, Chisaki was expecting Izuku to stay and be deflowered within the week. He had made some extravagant plans for it and he had to cancel the venue he reserved, losing his deposit in the process.

Now, because of his unhappiness, he was requesting a full seven days with Izuku.

Tomura's reply to the email was reluctant in the same way as a merchant who was being haggled for their most prized possession—but they still needed to make the sale. He accepted the new deal to soothe things over but with little joy.

Reading that exchange was a slap of harsh reality.

Somehow in the haze of this pink paradise, Izuku forgot the fact his virginity was spoken for. He became seasick at the thought of being with Chisaki for an entire *week*.

Izuku turned his eyes towards Katsuki. Instantly, the second he saw his favorite shade of red, he felt a little bit better.

Izuku sheepishly smiled and said, "I, uh, have to go call my handler A.S.A.P. Should we head upstairs?"

"I have to call my boss too," Katsuki replied. Katsuki fiddled with his phone and his eyes skirted away. "I…I should probably do it in private, so I think I'm going to find a spot elsewhere. No offense."

He didn't trust Izuku.

"Uh, yeah, you're right," Izuku agreed quickly. He attempted to hide his embarrassment. He forgot that easily that in real life they disliked each other. "Here, let me take your bag upstairs for you."

Before Katsuki could protest, Izuku grabbed Katsuki's bag. He hoisted it up with ease and walked quickly towards the elevators.

When he got to their hotel room, his shoulders sagged with emotions too large for his body.

He quickly felt caught in a tug of war between obligation and his own desire as his mind bounced between visions of Chisaki and Katsuki. At one end was the Yakuza and their threats they always made good on. On the other side was his desire to be with Kacchan that could never be killed after all these years.

But in the middle was Izuku, tied at the waist and strangled for air.

However, all it took was a single thought about Tomura to dispel all thoughts of *choice*.

Izuku quietly called his brother. He was surprised to find himself once again forwarded to voicemail, so he decided to text him instead.

[You]: I read the email. We can set the date when I come back.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku tried his best to push thoughts about Chisaki and Tomura to the side, but it was hard. With thoughts of Chisaki came thoughts of Tomura. And with Tomura came thoughts of endless destruction and doom that would mean Katsuma being trapped in the underground of Tokyo forever.

But there was one thing he found that kept him away from the darkest recesses of his mind—

His eyes roamed the figure in front of him.

He smiled a bit looking at Katsuki's muscular back as the man talked. He was discussing the mission and their next move, but Izuku could barely care. Moore was his secondary worry now. Killing him was going to be easy, all they needed to do was convince the human trafficker that they didn't kill that guy in the woods and figure out when the cops were planning their raid.

Right as Izuku was surveying Katsuki's thick quads, suddenly Katsuki tilted his head at him and smirked.

"Did you get a good enough look?" Katsuki teased sarcastically. "I can turn to the side for you if you need another angle."

Izuku quickly turned away. "I-I wasn't looking at you. I was zoning out."

"Yah-huh. Sure you weren't." Katsuki rolled his eyes. "Well, what now?"

"We should wait until dinner when we see Shouto and Inasa again," Izuku suggested. "We'll poke around then with some questions. But uh, maybe we can relax in the lounge area? We have to pretend like we didn't dispose of the bartender in the woods so hiding away only

makes us look suspicious right now. But if we go to the bar lounge and look ignorant, it'll seem like we don't know anything. Let me buy you a drink or something."

"Buy me a drink, huh?" Katsuki repeated with a hint of amusement.

Izuku furrowed his brow. Why was that weird?

With that horrible handsome grin, Katsuki leaned in and said, "Why does that sound like you're flirting with me, nerd?"

Izuku spluttered and blushed at the implication.

"I-I'm not!" Izuku denied swiftly. He threw his hands up defensively and shook his head. "I-I was only being nice."

"You sure? First you gawk at me and now you want to buy me a drink. Doesn't sound just nice to me."

"Nevermind, Katsuki," Izuku mumbled, his face totally red. "Why do you always make such crude comments?"

"I'm not the one offering to buy you a drink, Deku. Next time just ask me on a date."

Izuku spluttered. Heat burned through his cheeks at the thought of going on a *date* with Katsuki. He hated how he could easily imagine himself and Kacchan on a date here. There were so many options, and it would be so easy to—

No.

No. Izuku. Absolutely not.

"Just forget it," Izuku hissed. "Disregard that I ever offered."

He stood up quickly and walked right out of their room to hide his pink cheeks. Behind him, Katsuki laughed like a goddamn hyena. He walked up to Izuku, elbowed him in the side playfully and winked.

Quickly, all the melancholy in his body vanished.

Kacchan had grown up healthy, that's for sure.

A perfectly healthy menace.



By the time they made it to the bar in the lounge, Izuku found himself wanting to ask Katsuki all sorts of questions. He processed his shock successfully and now all he wanted to do was know Katsuki more.

He followed the pull in his heart and held Katsuki's hand gently. He hoped Katsuki wouldn't say anything about it, and he was right. Katsuki held his hand right back with slight confusion—but he didn't make a move to pull away.

Izuku took the extended kindness and began asking Katsuki questions.

Did he still live in Tokyo?

What kind of music did he listen to?

Was he super popular and always surrounded by a ton of people?

Izuku asked every question he could think of. With every answer he got, it made his heart swell with happiness.

"I lived in a lot of places, honestly, but I settled down in a city near Tokyo," Katsuki answered with a shrug. "Ain't telling you which city though."

"I listen to a lot of alternative music and jazz as well," Katsuki answered as he ordered another pineapple cocktail.

"I was popular but not for reasons you think," Katsuki chuckled. "I was well known for beating other kids' asses."

Izuku smiled with each new detail. He got lost in Katsuki as they chatted and was entirely unaware he was tracing small circles on top of Katsuki's hand.

As he watched Katsuki eat the pineapple from his drink, it was obvious he really liked pineapple. Izuku immediately perked up, looked Katsuki up and down, and was once again overjoyed by how large and healthy Katsuki was.

At that, Izuku's nurturing nature took hold. He wanted to keep taking care of Kacchan so he plucked the pineapple from his drink and handed it over happily.

Blinded by the nostalgia, Izuku thought Katsuki would eat it like a normal human. But he was sorely mistaken when Katsuki grew suspicious. Izuku paused under his gaze and when Katsuki began to suck heavily at that pineapple, Izuku was bluntly reminded that Kacchan was *Katsuki*.

Izuku froze, entirely taken back as Katsuki licked, sucked, and practically fucked the goddamn fruit. Katsuki began to poke at him, and then without fail, leaned forward until their lips almost touched.

Izuku was about to lean away but then Katsuki said something that flipped Izuku on his head:

"You've been awfully nice to me all day, and that usually means one of two things," Katsuki whispered, dropping his voice seductively low. "You either pity me after what I spilled during the camping trip, or you want to fuck me. Which is it?"

Izuku's brain went haywire when he suddenly envisioned them desperately kissing and imagined their usual push and pull melting into intense, passionate sex.

Then immediately a vision of Chisaki bombarded Izuku.

The brakes slammed on Izuku's thoughts with mental skid marks across his brain. Izuku graciously reminded himself that his body was spoken for, and eighty million yen was in play.

Izuku straightened himself out and stayed away from temptation.

ᔓᔓᔓ

He was saved from the situation by Moore and Koizumi coming up to them at the bar. The pair of men invited them into a private lounge for a game of billiards. This was clearly a test and Izuku was so happy how easily he and Katsuki passed.

It was a miracle, really. Six days and Katsuki was *finally* behaving like the perfect husband. They passed all the questions Koizumi and Moore gave with flying colors thanks to Katsuki's impeccable performance.

"You're doing great, darling."

"That's my husband, he's so talented."

"I love how fast you pick up on things. How did I get so damn lucky?"

Izuku knew it was all fake, but he wished it wasn't.

Every word was accompanied by a grin that was so bright Izuku thought he might go blind. He watched as Katsuki kept his eyes on him the whole time. They circled the pool table perfectly in sync and it made Izuku's heart both hurt and soar high in the clouds.

When they were left alone, Izuku found himself admiring how great Katsuki was.

Katsuki's eyes tethered with his and he kindly offered to teach him how to play billiards.

Then it rapidly divulged into something else. Izuku didn't know how or when—but the lessons in billiards began tumbling down the path of temptation that he was trying so *hard* to stray away from.

The sexual tension between them boiled over like a volcano.

Katsuki's hands were now cuffing both his wrists, pinning him on the pool table. His pelvis was pressed flush against Izuku's backside, and he used his whole body to cage Izuku in.

One flash of Katsuki's fiendish smile and all rational thoughts were lost.

Maybe losing his virginity bent over a billiards table wouldn't be the worst thing in the world.

Katsuki buried his head into the crook of his neck and Izuku's eyes fluttered closed. Soft lips grazed against his skin and left fire along his jugular. Izuku's breath hitched at the new sensation, and his touch starved body wasn't ready for it. His legs quaked viciously at the sudden intensity when Katsuki kept grinding into him.

"You didn't answer my question earlier," Katsuki whispered hotly against his flesh. "Which is it, Izuku? Fuck me or pity me?"

Katsuki rolled his hips harshly and Izuku shuddered.

Izuku short circuited, overwhelmed by the new sensations. "Shit. Kacc—K-Katsuki, wait—"

Suddenly, Tomura's ringtone cut through the air.

And *holy hell*.

The sound was the equivalent of a throwing bucket of ice water on his cock.

Izuku's eyes bulged wide at what he was doing. He sprung up, broke free of Katsuki's grasp and staggered at the sudden switch from warm to cold. He whipped his phone out of his pocket, and saw '117'. Instantly his boner began to deflate. Izuku modestly put his hand over his crotch and excused himself to take the call.

Izuku shakily breathed out. How was it possible that Kacchan grew up to be sex embodied? It was maddening.

He pressed answer and held the phone up to his ear.

"Hello?" Izuku asked quickly. He hoped that his breathlessness wasn't noticeable.

"Sorry I missed your call," Tomura said, not noting the tightness in Izuku's tone. "I was cleaning up the absolute mess of a trip we had."

"What happened?" Izuku questioned, hoping to give himself some time to catch his breath as Tomura talked.

"Well, long story short, One has a grudge that's stuck on his tail. Some years ago he offered a freelancing hitman that went by the alias 'Loud Cloud' a potential partnership to operate as an associate for The Academy. It comes back to haunt him periodically."

Izuku frowned but was intrigued slightly by the lore. "Why did he do that? One doesn't believe in working with outsiders."

"You're right, he doesn't. But he did it on purpose," Tomura explained. "At the time The Academy wasn't the first option clients went to. He needed to stomp out the competition by killing them off, but in a way that would just make it seem like everyone else was bad at their jobs. This way he would look better."

Sounds like One, Izuku thought. He was a perfectly conniving snake.

Tomura continued, “He would offer to work with his competition under false pretenses and befriend them. Then he would send them on very brutal assignments that he knew would be fatal. Loud Cloud was one of these and whoever that bastard’s best friend was is still trying to figure out what agency was responsible for sending him on such a dangerous mission.”

“How long ago was this?” Izuku muttered.

“Before we both were born, so nothing to really worry about,” Tomura said. “If whoever it was hasn’t been able to get their foot in the door now, they won’t ever.”

“Thirty years is a long time to hold a grudge,” Izuku said thoughtfully.

“Hate is the strongest emotion,” Tomura lectured. “But how’s the Moore assignment going?”

“It’s going fine,” Izuku lied. “The cops here are trying to raid the resort and arrest Moore. I am trying to figure out when the police raid will be so I can exterminate Moore before that.”

“Good.” Tomura let out a long exhale. “Let me know when that will be so I can give Chisaki an estimate of when you’ll be back. He wants to make sure he has a full week available.”

Izuku swallowed. Now he was entirely sobered up.

“Okay,” Izuku whispered. He hung his head a bit. “Sounds good.”

He wearily looked over his shoulder at the door that held Katsuki on the other side.

ᔓᔓᔓ

With every ounce of self-control he possessed, Izuku gathered himself well enough to escape Katsuki’s temptation. He made up some excuse about wanting dinner and practically ran out of the room.

Dinner provided useful information. They learned the police raid would be in four days, and somehow, by a stroke of luck, Japan’s traveling carnival was in town. Izuku almost didn’t believe his ears at how perfectly it all aligned.

Izuku took the carnival as an undeniable sign from Fate to tell Katsuki the truth.

He could see it now: they would be walking hand in hand underneath the Ferris wheel, and Izuku would get them alone. He would reveal the truth and Katsuki’s beautiful red eyes would go wide. All the years of nostalgia would envelope them like a cocoon as they were reunited at the same place they were torn apart.

It would be perfect, like a novel.

Izuku smiled to himself.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When they made their way back up to their room, Izuku was admittedly dead tired. The lack of effective sleep was catching up. In his hazy head, all the events of the exhausting day were swimming together: finding Kacchan, the gentle touches, the smiles, the strange sexual tension and then finally, the *carnival*.

It was a lot to process.

“You’re really fucking sleepy huh?” Katsuki asked with a hint of mirth.

Izuku nodded with his eyes closed.

“Extremely, I can barely think straight,” Izuku muttered with a light yawn. He grabbed a fresh set of pajamas, a towel, and started to make his way to the shower. “If I’m not out in twenty minutes, please come check on me. I sometimes fall asleep in the shower when I’m tired like this.”

“Will do. Good night, Izuku,” Katsuki said a little too happily.

“Goodnight, Kacchan,” Izuku replied.

Both men froze.

“...What did you call me?” Katsuki asked slowly.

All the happiness in his voice vanished.

Izuku’s blood went cold, and he now was wide awake. He whirled around to Katsuki when he realized his mistake.

Hurt, mortification and betrayal were written all over Katsuki’s face.

Quickly Izuku tried to fix it. He tried to tell him, but Katsuki’s pain was too big for any words to get around it. A storm kicked up, and Katsuki proved to be the typhoon Izuku thought he was.

Katsuki’s face twisted into a nasty scowl as pure hatred for Izuku poured from him. All the stab wounds, bullet holes, and punches were nothing compared to this. Izuku tried to get him to calm down, but it was useless.

“Listen to me carefully because I don’t deal with *bullshit* like that,” Katsuki threatened. “People like you don’t get to use that nickname, so you need to erase it from your goddamn memory.”

Like a stone being thrown at a glass house, Izuku’s armor cracked under those words.

“People like me?” Izuku echoed. “What does *that* mean?”

“It means *fucked up* people like you.” Katsuki’s words sliced into him and damaged Izuku’s deepest insecurity. “People who don’t fucking flinch when I snap a man’s neck. Fucked up people who murder a man in cold blood in front of another. Fucked up people like you who

have been a goddamn *thorn* in my side for years. You don't get to corrupt that memory for me with how fucked up you are because I already am fucked up enough to taint it *myself*."

The pain spread slowly. All the cracks spread around Izuku's heart until it shattered.

He'd been right. Katsuki would not want to know it was him. He hated him. Kacchan hated him. Shame, hurt, and disgust for himself weighed further on Izuku's broken heart until his face crumbled.

"I'm going to go get some air, don't wait up for me," Katsuki whispered. He hung his head away to hide his eyes.

Izuku watched as Katsuki walked out of the room. He slammed the door behind him hard enough that all the pictures on the walls rattled.

Izuku stayed rooted in place, unable to move.

The perfect scenario he had put together about telling Katsuki it was him at the carnival disintegrated in mere seconds. It was wiped away under the notion that his life was not a perfect novel. There would be no magical reunion.

And worst of all, the boy from his childhood grew up to be a fucking *asshole*.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Katsuki didn't come back for hours.

Izuku sat alone in the room. He stared blankly at every single heart on the wall. They mocked him. They laughed in his face how he would never possess real love, or even feel it. He wasn't worthy of it, and it would remain forever out of his reach.

The new heaviness of emotions in Izuku's ribcage was too much. He held his hand up above his heart and clawed at his shirt. When the feeling transformed to mimicking lead sitting in his gut, Izuku did the only thing he could do to relieve it.

He grabbed his violin case and left.

He found the private rose garden maze in the back of the hotel. It was beautiful. Every bush twisted upon itself in a lovely interwinding way. Izuku dragged his body down every path that was paved with brown gravel and silver stones. Each way he turned was a new arch way that was something directly out of his daydreams.

Izuku stopped when he came to the mouth of one opening. It was a perfect circle, and in the center was a marble fountain donning a sculpture of a weeping woman cradling a large vase that had a steady stream of water. Izuku's eyes softened as he looked at the unique art. He understood her pain somehow and was drawn to it, so he sat underneath her.

Izuku took out his violin and began to play.

He played the one song he knew by heart, The Dance of The Love Birds.

He closed his eyes and allowed himself to be carried away. With every note he saw their lives. He saw Katsuki when he was a child, and now as an adult. With the increasing tempo he saw Vienna and with the low notes he saw their fist fights. It all mangled together like the song in complex layers.

"…Izuku," Katsuki whispered uneasily into the dark night. "It was you?"

Izuku's eyes snapped open, and he stopped playing abruptly.

He turned harshly to see Katsuki standing there with his eyes irritated and bloodshot exactly like his. Izuku had a visceral reaction. He needed to leave because he couldn't take any more heartbreak right now.

He staggered as he tried to quickly pack up his violin. He rushed to do it and get out before Katsuki could say anything hurtful—

Katsuki ran forward and tried to stop him, but Izuku was always quicker.

"W-Wait—Izuku—"

Izuku gritted his teeth as tears fell from his eyes. He couldn't do this right now. He didn't want to be called a goddamn freak. Izuku slipped out of Katsuki's grasp and darted into the dark maze. He didn't look back as he tried to leave the ghost of his past behind him.

It hurt. Why did it hurt?

"Izuku!" Katsuki called out with desperation. His voice cracked at the end, and Izuku hated how it pulled to him. "Izuku—fuck. *Wait*—"

Suddenly, Katsuki grabbed both of his arms. Izuku hissed through his tears as he was yanked backwards by the whirlpool of a man. Izuku twisted his body immediately to escape, and his violin went crashing down to the ground.

Then it began: the push and pull they were always tethered to.

They began colliding like two twin stars about to implode on impact. Every time Izuku thought he got free, Katsuki dragged him back and forced him to stay. They always were like this: Izuku running and Katsuki chasing. Now they were back in that rhythm, but Izuku couldn't do it tonight.

He couldn't hurt himself like this anymore.

"G-Get off of me," Izuku's broken voice begged.

Katsuki gritted his teeth and shook his head. "J-Just wait a moment—"

"—No, let me go you *asshole*—"

The next few moments were a tidal wave. Izuku harshly yanked himself away one more time and tripped in the process. But because Katsuki's grip on him refused to let go, the two of them went toppling down on the soft grass. Katsuki landed on top of him, still trying to pin him to stay still.

They struggled back and forth like coarse, clashing waves in a storm.

It was only when Katsuki wrapped his arms around Izuku from behind, restraining his arms to his sides, did they finally stop.

Izuku could barely hear anything over his heartbeat. Izuku dropped his head in defeat, too tired to continue and too tired to face what Katsuki's reaction to the truth might be.

"Please." Izuku's voice was hoarse and heavy. "Let go."

"I can't," Katsuki replied in the most raw, broken voice.

It stunned Izuku. Katsuki was on the edge of breaking down, and his hands were shaking like he was terrified.

"I can't let go. I've been trying my whole life, but I *can't*," Katsuki said shakily.

Katsuki's hold on him melted from keeping him captive to hugging him desperately. Izuku froze during this shift.

Katsuki hugged him closer, and tears hit the back of Izuku's neck.

Slowly, Katsuki's whole body began to rock like he was stuck in a storm. He nestled Izuku closer and all of Izuku's temper was extinguished. His fears collapsed on themselves and his need to flee vanished when he felt Katsuki's heart beat out of control.

They stayed there, not moving, simply listening to each other breathing. Izuku lifted his own hand to place over Katsuki's trembling one.

"Is…is it really you?" Katsuki questioned with a splintering crack. "Was it you that year in Tokyo?"

Izuku hesitated, terrified that all his worst nightmares were about to come true with the next word.

"Y-Yes."

Izuku turned around in Katsuki's arms and faced his fears.

"Did you know?" Katsuki asked. "This whole time?"

"No." Izuku shook his head and screwed his eyes shut. "I figured it out at the campfire when you mentioned being called 'Kacchan'."

"Why didn't you say something sooner?"

“I—I don’t know,” Izuku whispered. He opened his eyes and set his vulnerable gaze on Katsuki. “I-I thought about saying something. All night and all day today, I wanted to tell you, but I didn’t know how. E-Especially after all this time. It was messing with me. Like *really* messing with my head. You have to be feeling weird about all of this too, aren’t you?”

“Of course. It feels like—”

Fate.

Izuku waited for Katsuki to say that word.

But it never came because Katsuki didn’t believe in fate.

“It feels like a really big coincidence,” Katsuki finished, tapering off into a whisper.

Izuku gazed at him, not believing that a coincidence was the correct word choice. But he didn’t want to push it.

“Yeah. A coincidence,” Izuku whispered.

Katsuki stared at him for what seemed like forever. Izuku wished he knew what he was thinking, but all he could think about was sleep. Tiredness tugged at his eyelids, and he waited for the hammer of Katsuki’s outburst to hit. But nothing came.

“We should go back upstairs,” Katsuki whispered instead.

Katsuki subconsciously drew closer, and his eyes were expressing a million and one emotions.

But neither anger nor disgust were there.

ɯɯɯ

Seventh Day in Paradise

When the next day came it felt like a dream.

Izuku was awoken by the smell of savory food and green tea. He was immediately on edge, and when he saw the time, he completely panicked. Never in his life had he slept in on an assignment. He started flailing around, but stopped when Katsuki calmly told him to relax. Izuku paused for a moment to take in everything.

Somehow Katsuki was already awake, fully dressed and he was ushering in two full platters of food.

Then Katsuki revealed the food to be Izuku’s favorite: Katsudon.

Izuku stared at the steamy egg and pork cutlet in utter surprise. Did Katsuki remember what his favorite food was somehow or was this a stroke of luck? Izuku could only recall mentioning that katsudon was his favorite food once during dinner rather offhandedly.

Katsuki sat down at the tiny table in their hotel room, poured two cups of tea and picked up his chopsticks.

Izuku was confused. Why wasn't Katsuki yelling?

"Are you just going to stand there or are you going to eat?" Katsuki asked, mildly impatient.

"S-Shouldn't we be working on taking out Moore?" Izuku responded wearily.

Katsuki frowned. "I think Moore can wait a day or two. Shouto basically hinted the police raid isn't for another four days. We have time."

Izuku nodded before shyly walking over to the table. "Right."

When he sat down, Katsuki kept stealing glances at him. He eyed him up and down like he was from an entirely different dimension.

They ate mostly in quietness that was full of curious stares and shy looks on Izuku's behalf.

As he chewed on the juicy pork cutlet, Izuku felt a bit guilty for thinking Katsuki's reaction to him would be volatile. He assumed the worst in him, and he was pleasantly surprised to find Katsuki was not disgusted in the least bit. Katsuki was shocked, first and foremost, but overall, he radiated that he was eager to get to know Izuku.

After they finished eating, they stayed cooped up in the room all day answering each other's questions that had been burning in their minds for over a decade.

"What happened? O-Or where did you go?" Izuku whispered, barely inaudible. "I know you mentioned your mother b-but I…I worried something bad happened to you that day. I thought maybe someone kidnapped you at the carnival because I was late. Or worse."

"My mother came and found me that day," Katsuki answered. "She said we would come back —but we never did. She feared ever setting foot in Tokyo again for some reason so…we didn't."

Izuku was sad, but happy to know Katsuki went straight to where he belonged that day.

Izuku gave a forced smile. "I-I'm glad you found her again."

"I came back to Tokyo when I was thirteen," Katsuki confessed. Izuku's breathing stopped slightly. "I went to the church, and it was still there. I—I went inside of the nook."

At this, Izuku averted his eyes. He thought about the note he left as a child that scribbled the words "I love you" on it.

Then Katsuki asked the question that'd been teetering on his own tongue.

"What about that older brother of yours?" Katsuki's voice wobbled. "Did he ever stop hurting you?"

It pained Izuku to hear it, but he saw no reason to lie. “No. He didn’t.”

Katsuki hung his head and clasped his hands. He gave Izuku a look that was worth a thousand apologies.

“I’m…I’m so fucking sorry, Izuku.”

“You have nothing to be sorry for. It’s not your fault,” Izuku said earnestly.

“It is. I left you there. You were being hurt, and I left you.”

“But you were a *kid*,” Izuku emphasized. “You were a kid who was left abandoned in a giant city waiting for an irresponsible adult to come back. Then she did. You did what any child would’ve done in that moment if they were reunited with a parent who loved them. S-Some things in life aren’t controllable for us all the time. This was one of those things.”

Izuku didn’t blame Katsuki at all.

Katsuki’s mother, no matter how capricious, loved him and ultimately, she *did* come back for him. If Izuku’s mother ever decided she loved him and did the same, he probably would go with her too no matter how old he was.

“Do you still see your brother?” Katsuki asked after a stretch of silence.

“Um. Yes. Our living arrangements are complicated,” Izuku confessed, slightly nervous. “But —I try my best to put distance between us for obvious purposes.”

At the mention of Tomura again, Izuku realized Katsuki was going to want to know more about his mysterious home life. But he hadn’t thought that far ahead. How would he tell Katsuki about The Viper Academy? *Should* he even tell him?

“Is that the reason you took this type of job? To try to get away from him?” Katsuki dug further.

“No.” Izuku frowned. Where did that come from?

“But you said you do this job to survive,” Katsuki said slowly as if it was obvious.

“I do,” Izuku said. “But he has nothing to do with that.”

“Then why?” Katsuki exasperated. “Why would someone as kind—or was as kind as you—go into this type of shit? *Willingly*?”

Izuku soured at the mention of free will.

People who believed everything in life was a choice inherited a privilege they would never truly grasp.

“I don’t fucking get it,” Katsuki continued. “You were so kind, gentle, and well off. You weren’t meant for this type of life. I always thought you would go on to be a teacher or go

into a profession that helped people. Not kill them."

The internal battle going on in Katsuki's head was evident and Izuku could do nothing but sadly watch.

Part of him hoped that on the day they would be reunited, Kacchan would be accepting of him—*all* sides of him. But as Katsuki sat in front of him now, Izuku didn't think that was going to happen. This was exactly how Tomura said others would react if they knew the truth.

He kept his mouth shut about how he was raised to kill.

"I'm sorry I didn't turn out how you wanted me to," Izuku muttered sarcastically. "I know you think I'm *fucked up* but please understand not everything in the world is a simple choice. My apologies for tainting that memory for you."

Katsuki licked his lips and shook his head. "I didn't mean it like that."

"You did," Izuku bitterly cut off. "It's fine. I know I'm fucked up, alright? I get it. I always had a feeling you would be disappointed about what I am if we ever met again. I know I'm not normal."

"I'm sorry," Katsuki said quietly. "You're not any more messed up than I am. I actually always assumed you would be disappointed in me if you saw what I grew up to be."

"I'm not, if that helps." Izuku gave him a sad smile. "I'm really just happy that you grew up. I assumed you were dead. Y-You hadn't taken any of your stuff with you, and I struggled to understand why you didn't want to bring your favorite toy with you if you had left. Knowing you're alive is…all I could really ask for."

Katsuki's eyes softened to a level Izuku never thought was possible.

"I shouldn't have snapped on you like that yesterday," Katsuki apologized. He placed his hand above Izuku's tenderly. "I was out of line."

"No, it's alright. You should've," Izuku rebutted, trying to ignore how his heart sped up at the slightest bit of contact. "I hadn't said anything. As far as you knew I was simply some guy who you've been fighting with for years using a nickname that was dear to you. It made you uncomfortable. And if it still makes you uncomfortable, I won't ever use it again."

Katsuki stared at him like he suggested throwing a puppy in a volcano.

The visible hurt in his eyes was potent and immediately Izuku regretted ever suggesting never saying Kacchan again.

"I don't care if you use it or not," Katsuki mumbled and averted his eyes to the side. "That's your choice, I guess."

Izuku's heart skipped a beat, still unsure if that was a yes or a no.

“If you don’t mind, I would love to hear about your life after the carnival day,” Izuku whispered with a smile to skillfully move the topic off himself.

“Sure, on one condition,” Katsuki wagered.

“What would that be?”

“You buy the next round of food,” Katsuki said. The corners of his lips tugged upwards ever so slightly. Not a full smile, but enough that it made Izuku smile more at him in return. “I’m still starving.”

“I think that’s manageable.” Izuku laughed slightly.

Katsuki leaned in and Izuku’s heart fluttered. The light caught the emerald on Katsuki’s ring finger, and suddenly the matching wedding rings were taboo but *right*. Shyness crept into Izuku when Katsuki tenderly smiled at him all the way.

They were officially reunited and deep in Izuku’s heart, he never wanted them to be torn apart again.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Once the awkwardness wore off, their reunion was wonderful. The rest of the day they spent catching up, and Izuku allowed Katsuki to tell him about his life after the carnival. There was so much to Katsuki that unraveled.

But particularly what stood out is when Katsuki began talking about his mother.

The shift in his demeanor was plain as day. Izuku could feel the heaviness that was chained to Katsuki’s heart when he thought about his mother, and it brought Izuku sadness too. Then Katsuki explained more of the details surrounding her death. And Izuku was mortified to learn she was *murdered* by a drug lord who lied about what an assignment was.

If there was one thing Izuku hated, it was clients who lied about assignments.

Tomura, One, and Nine encountered a few of them over the years. They were truly the slimiest people with wicked grins. Their grubby hands would perpetually put assassins at risk like they were nothing but disposable property. It usually happened because these types of weasels were too cheap to pay full price for whatever they wanted done.

Any time it happened, Izuku undoubtedly felt bitter afterwards.

If Katsuki’s mother died by the hands of someone as grimy as that, then Katsuki deserved to get his justice.

“What was his name?” Izuku asked. He was angry on Katsuki’s behalf knowing her life was unnecessarily cut short.

“Akaguro Chizome,” Katsuki spat the name like it was rotten. “Ring any bells?”

“No,” Izuku said honestly. “I’ve never heard of him.”

Izuku imprinted that name into his memory: Akaguro Chizome.

He tried to search in his head for such a person, but he drew a giant blank.

Izuku was familiar with countless people in the Tokyo underground and all their affiliates, but he never encountered a Chizome. If he had, Izuku would point Katsuki in his direction and happily supply him with the ammo.

“I hope you’re planning on getting even with him,” Izuku said. “He shouldn’t be allowed to get away with that if he was the person who lied about what the assignment was.”

“I’m going to get my revenge when I have the time,” Katsuki said. “Right now, I’m focused on the assignments I’m given. Ironic in a way. I took this job to keep us both alive, but it wound up causing her death. When the moment comes, I’ll go back for that bastard and all his goons.”

Izuku nodded. “Good.”

The love Katsuki held for his mother was admirable. His eyes would soften whenever she was mentioned. And when her death was brought up, the pain Katsuki endured could be felt across the seven seas. Because of that, it was easy to conclude that Katsuki deserved his revenge.

Izuku hoped Chizome’s death was as agonizing as everything Katsuki had to go through because of her murder.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When the sky was a dust orange, they found themselves in a flow of normalcy. A broken piece of Izuku was mended together stitch by stitch with every smile Katsuki gave him.

It was like long lost friends finally coming together and it was the most tranquil Izuku ever felt. Katsuki was shaping up to be the perfect blend of what he thought Kacchan would be like: courageous, funny, and charming.

As he talked to Katsuki though, he wondered if his previous asshole demeanor was all just a facade. The switch from last night to now was leaving Izuku with a bit of whiplash. There was always softness in Katsuki that peaked through his prickly outside, but now it felt like it was entirely gone with the reveal.

It was nearly the day’s end, and they hadn’t left the room. Izuku could bask in Katsuki’s presence for the rest of his life, potentially. And that realization made his chest feel like it was scorched with powerful yearning.

Jirou stopped by the room to drop off the comics they briefly discussed during dinner and Izuku felt like a kid again. Suddenly, it was only the two of them back in the abandoned

church with the smell of burnt candle wax filling the room. The dusty cobwebs were a sign of safety and the foggy stainless glass illuminated everything in speckles of rainbows.

They read through the comics like old times, and even built a tiny tent like they used to.

While under the covers, Izuku's heart was working overtime.

Listening to Katsuki read to him healed him more. He never knew he would be so relieved to see Katsuki *literate*. Katsuki was healthy, strong, and smart. Izuku couldn't help himself when he compared the side of his hand to Katsuki's bicep while Katsuki read. He could barely wrap his fingers around the taut muscle, and it made something in his core hum with delight.

When Katsuki finished reading, Izuku delicately cupped Katsuki's cheek. He slowly stroked Katsuki's skin and appreciated every second that they spent together.

Katsuki's eyes locked on to him at the touch and he shifted in slightly closer.

It was here that Izuku was suddenly conscious of the position of their bodies.

They both were turned inwards, laying on their sides. Katsuki held his head propped up with one hand as he leaned over Izuku's head that was resting on the pillow. Their legs were tangled with Katsuki's long limbs locking him in. Every soft breath grazed against Izuku's lips, beckoning him to Katsuki.

Just when Izuku thought they couldn't get closer, they did.

Katsuki leaned down by an inch.

His tempting eyes went half lidded and he was gazing at Izuku in a way he never had before. Yesterday, Katsuki's gaze was clearly laced with lust and every time he blinked, Izuku was sure he undressed a bit of him with his eyes.

But now, Katsuki was staring at him like he was someone precious.

It nearly looked like Katsuki wanted to kiss him dearly.

"W-We should get ready for bed," Izuku said quietly, suddenly feeling shy. "It's getting late."

"…Okay," Katsuki whispered. His raspy voice grazed the bottom of his vocal cords as they stared into each other.

Katsuki didn't make a move.

Izuku didn't either.

Like forbidden fruit hanging from a tree, Katsuki dangled in front of Izuku. Izuku was torn on whether he should lean in or lean away because all he wanted to do was sink his lips into Katsuki's and have a quick taste.

Ultimately, his nerves got the better of him in the heat of the moment. He'd never really been kissed, and from what it seemed like, Katsuki was an expert. Izuku decided he needed a minute to think and weigh out what was going on in his head.

He quickly excused himself and headed straight for the shower.

While the hot water beat down on his back, Izuku rested his heavy head against the tiled wall. The coolness of the surface contrasted the burning need that rattled in his core.

Izuku ghosted his fingers over his lips, still able to feel Katsuki's hot breath lingering there.

Like a small seed, the thought of kissing Katsuki took root inside of his mind. It sprouted tiny, but strong roots with just a sprinkle of curiosity to keep it watered. Izuku always wondered what it would be like to kiss the terribly handsome stranger he met in Vienna. Even more so, he always wished to kiss Kacchan if they ever were reunited. Now he had two for the price of one foul mouthed blond.

Izuku nervously jittered his leg in the shower as he began to weigh all the different variables at play.

Once he came to his conclusion, Izuku shyly smiled.

Neither Chisaki and Tomura would ever find out if he kissed Katsuki and this was something that he wanted to do for *years*.

Besides, one small innocent kiss couldn't hurt anything.



Eighth Day in Paradise

When Izuku woke up the next day, he was determined to get his dream kiss.

Something between them shifted dramatically and it was both frightening yet exciting. Their new energy was docile enough to test the waters and do something that Izuku would call absurd under any other circumstances. But under these, very real fateful circumstances, Izuku decided to say it was like the stars were aligning.

Because what better way to have his first real, adult kiss than with the same person from his childhood?

It would be like a souvenir or something of the sort at this point. Izuku reasoned that they didn't have to go any further than an innocent kiss. Plus, after what was uncovered, it would be almost purely sentimental.

Izuku struggled to reason it fully because all he really knew was that he wanted to kiss Katsuki.

Figuring out the aftermath could come later.

They needed to wait until nightfall for the carnival, but Izuku already knew he wanted to kiss Katsuki at the top of the Ferris wheel.

Was he once again painting a picture-perfect scene that was straight out a novel? Sure. Could anyone blame him? No. *Especially* not Katsuki since he was the whole reason he was hyper fixated on romantic gestures.

When nighttime came, Izuku spent a crazy long time agonizing over his outfit in the bathroom.

What clothes would make him look the most kissable? Katsuki always squinted if there was too much bright pink in his outfit. Maybe the color gave him a headache, Izuku nervously concluded. He decided to choose his white blouse and dark jeans to be easy on the eyes.

But now, he needed to think about the rest of the outfit. What shoes would allow for maximum height difference to make sure Katsuki had to lean down like Jack did in the Titanic movie?

He clutched his head in pain when a headache zapped him.

This was all so painstaking. Izuku groaned lightly when his messy hair didn't curl the way he wanted.

"C'mon, you're holding up everyone," Katsuki shouted from the other side of the bathroom impatiently. "That bird's nest of yours wasn't combed all day yesterday. You're not going to make it look nice now."

"Fine, fine. I'm coming," Izuku grumbled.

He stepped out of the bathroom unsure if he looked kissable. But the second Katsuki saw him, all Izuku's fears melted away.

Katsuki's eyebrows shot up and there was massive surprise plastered across his face. His gorgeous red eyes roamed up and down Izuku's figure, and for once Izuku didn't mind being ogled. He was happy to have Katsuki's attention on him and he hoped he could keep it for the rest of the night.

"This is the part where you tell me I look hideous," Izuku flirted with a light hint of sarcasm.

He nervously smiled and fidgeted with the ring on his finger.

"Yeah," Katsuki whispered, still dazed. "I suppose it is." There was a trickle of silence as they regarded each other. "This is also the part where you tell me to stop staring."

Izuku nodded distantly and echoed his words. "I suppose it is."

Izuku ogled Katsuki right back and was unsurprised that he was once more dressed in all black. But it suited him well and made his eyes and hair stand out.

Katsuki cleared his throat and walked towards him with a hint of blush adoring his cheeks.

Katsuki held his hand out and Izuku happily took it.

ᔓᔓᔓ

They both stared up at the candy-colored carnival sign. It flickered perfectly in sync as opposed to the last time either of them saw it, Izuku assumed. The smell of buttery popcorn, salty pretzels, and flavor filled treats wafted directly into his nose. He closed his eyes to let it sit in his chest and he exhaled into pure relaxation.

All around were colorful crowds of people passing them by. Some were people Izuku recognized from the resort. Some were holding hands and others were bulking together in groups. Everyone was giggling and pointing towards the rollercoasters and large Ferris wheel in the background.

It was exactly how it was all those years ago.

This was an alignment that Izuku planned not to waste.

Mina and Eijirou took it upon themselves to give everyone fuchsia colored feather boas. At first Katsuki made a disgusted face, but Izuku was so delighted because this only added to the moment. He tickled Katsuki's nose with the end of his boa and made the other man pause and laugh slightly.

"Let's have a good time tonight," Izuku said with a candid grin. "What do you say?"

Katsuki smiled at him how he used to and squeezed their interwoven hands. "Alright. Let's have some fun."

Izuku put his heart glasses on and his world was tinted with rosy-hues. He grinned from ear to ear as he decided to view everything the way he always wanted to: hopelessly romantic.

As they walked around the carnival, their whole group had a blast.

The bright pink boas they slung across their shoulders made Izuku giggle in delight. It was a perfect evening as everything fell into place. Izuku got to see his first aerobatics show and Katsuki won the strong man competition. There was even a point where Izuku was able to win Katsuki a teddy bear and it made him grin with delight at how Katsuki really did like the stuffed animal.

The new intensity of emotions in Izuku's chest suddenly felt at home for the first time. And also for the first time, Izuku didn't repress how he was feeling. He felt pure joy when Katsuki smiled at him. He screamed in excitement while on the rollercoaster. And he was happily amused when they decided to do Bumper Cars and Katsuki rammed his car into his over and over.

And lastly, Izuku experienced a daunting, carnal *want* when Katsuki went apple bobbing.

It was a stupid bet originally. Inasa offhandedly mentioned being the master of apple bobbing and for some reason Eijirou decided to make it a manliness competition. He rushed to take

Momo, Katsuki, Inasa, and himself to the front and the four people from their group lined up.

They stood with their hands placed neatly behind their backs. In front of them was a giant barrel of red apples floating on top of water.

“Is there a prize if we win?” Katsuki asked the worker.

“The prize will be a giant plate of churros!” The employee announced.

Like magic, the carnival worker materialized a plate full of several dozen churros stacked high to the sky. Izuku’s eyes must’ve gone so wide because they suddenly felt dry. He gasped in amazement before he could stop himself, and in turn earned a curious glance from Katsuki.

Izuku didn’t notice when Katsuki studied him for a split second then cracked his neck.

“Alright, listen up, Extras. Those churros are mine,” Katsuki suddenly declared. “You all might as well give up now.”

“So overly cocky,” Inasa said with a hearty laugh.

“Confidence is very manly!” Eijirou agreed with a bright grin. “Love the enthusiasm for churros!”

“On your marks, get set, go!” The carnival worker yelled and then blew his whistle.

Izuku couldn’t peel his eyes away. Katsuki dunked his head in and out of the water with a speed he didn’t think was possible. He expertly maneuvered the apples from the barrel of water to the basket beside him like he’d done this a million times before.

The water went almost everywhere in his hair, and it dripped down his shirt and pants. Izuku forgot how to breathe, and he didn’t even notice a full minute passed.

When the whistle blew to signal time was up, Katsuki had an apple in his mouth.

He immediately locked eyes with Izuku in the crowd with his hair dripping wet, and his shirt clinging to his chest. The thin black fabric was nearly see-through now because Izuku perfectly saw the dips and hills of his chest and abdomen.

“Ladies and gentlemen, we have ourselves a winner!” The carnival worker announced while pointing to Katsuki.

Katsuki smirked fiendishly with his teeth in the apple and winked at Izuku.

Izuku glanced down at the basket beside Katsuki, and it was the fullest out of everyone. No one else even came close. All the other competitors gave Katsuki a round of applause and were impressed by his dunking skills. Katsuki soaked up the praise like the arrogant sponge he was.

He stood up straight with earned smugness and ran his hand through his drenched hair. Izuku bit his lip as his heart skipped a beat.

Katsuki then took the apple out of his mouth with one hand, and with the other grabbed the giant plate of churros. He walked over to where Izuku was and politely handed the mountain of sweets to him.

“Here you go,” Katsuki mumbled. “All for you.”

Izuku was surprised. He looked down at the giant plate and grabbed it.

“You don’t want any?” Izuku asked.

“I hate sweets. I’ve always been more of a fruit guy.”

Katsuki held up the apple. He tossed it playfully before catching it and chomped a healthy bite out of the side.

Izuku watched as Katsuki sunk his teeth in the fruit and beads of water dripped down from his hair. Izuku’s eyes roamed down to Katsuki’s soaking wet chest that was at his eye level and bit his lip. He admired the way his silver chain was now glistening.

Any reservations about kissing Katsuki were fully gone with the wind.

ᔓᔓᔓ

After they finished gorging themselves on churros and cotton candy, they all decided to take a spin on the Ferris wheel.

“Have you ever been on a Ferris wheel?” Izuku asked as they stood in line. He teetered back and forth on his toes as he stared up at Katsuki.

“Nope,” Katsuki said with a pop at the end. He turned his head to smile at Izuku. “This will be my first time.”

“Me too. I guess we can experience it together.”

When it was their turn to get in, the carnival worker helped them inside of the pink cart with a welcoming smile. Izuku scooted in happily and Katsuki took a seat beside him. Izuku watched as Katsuki plopped the teddy bear on the side they didn’t sit on.

Izuku briefly examined the cart through his rose-tinted glasses and his heart clutched. It was perfect for his first real kiss. Twinkling fairy lights glittered atop the roof of the cart, and it brilliantly set a romantic mood.

Katsuki turned to look at the window as they started slowly rising up.

“Are you enjoying the sights?” Izuku asked.

Katsuki turned to look at him and it sent a jolt all the way down to Izuku’s fingertips.

“I am,” Katsuki agreed. “You seem like you’re enjoying yourself a bit more.”

“I think so, hah.” Izuku grinned timidly and shrugged his shoulders. “Only attempting to make my best of it while we’re here.”

“…Did you ever think about coming here? After I disappeared?” Katsuki asked as they rose higher in the sky.

“Of course. I thought about it all the time, I always wanted to go to this place.” Izuku tilted his head at him. “I know this is silly, but I thought a lot about coming back here with you. It feels…nice that we’re here. Together.”

Katsuki’s gaze softened and he confessed, “Me too. I…I thought about it a lot when I was a kid too. Sometimes I even imagined that if I found this carnival again, you’d just be here. Waiting. Especially because we always kept rambling about all that silly shit. The stuff about always coming back to each other.”

Izuku’s hope leapt to new heights.

Katsuki chuckled and bashfully rubbed at his nape. “It’s fucking stupid, I know, given that’s not how marriages work and we were just kids clinging to some dumb thing that made us happy.”

To Izuku, it wasn’t stupid at all.

It was more than perfect, and it made him happy in a way he had never experienced before. Knowing this whole time Katsuki wanted to see him again just as much as he did was groundbreaking. It was like two long lost jigsaw pieces finally coming together after being broken and tattered while away. Yet somehow, despite all the wear and tear they still fit together.

“Y’know, it’s fascinating,” Izuku whispered, looking at Katsuki through his pink glasses. “How it all worked out.”

“What do you mean?”

“Despite everything, we still came back to each other.”

“I guess we did. Didn’t we?” Katsuki whispered.

The look Katsuki was giving him now was enchanting. He was so sure Katsuki would want nothing to do with him once the cat was out of the bag, but he was dead wrong.

They were reunited and slowly everything was patching together.

Izuku’s heart clutched. He wondered what this meant for future assignments where they were always bound to run into each other repeatedly.

Fireworks went off in the background and illuminated everything. The glitter decorated the sky and the lights above Katsuki’s head curved along his handsome face perfectly. Izuku

inched his fingers forward to search for Katsuki's as they neared the top of the Ferris wheel.

Slowly, their hands interlocked, and their bodies moved like magnets. Katsuki's gaze from last night returned, and this time Izuku steeled his nerves. He looked at Katsuki's lips and leaned in slowly despite his racing heart.

Katsuki's other hand cradled his face lightly and Izuku leaned into the touch.

It felt right and his breath hitched when Katsuki took a finger and began playing with a curl in his hair. Izuku stared at Katsuki through his rose-colored glasses and closed his eyes when the other man leaned down fully.

Izuku gathered every ounce of courage and leaned in to kiss Katsuki.

"This…This is my last assignment," Katsuki whispered right before Izuku's lips touched his.

Izuku's eyes snapped open.

Everything halted.

The creak of the metal machine scratched through the silence.

Izuku leaned back to get a better look at Katsuki as his brain processed the words over and over again.

Katsuki's face was etched with guilt.

"What do you mean this is your last assignment?" Izuku asked, not wanting to be right. "Last like you're being fired?"

"Last as in after this I'm retiring for good," Katsuki whispered. "I filled my quota and contract requirements."

Izuku struggled to grasp the concept but slowly he understood it—and it threw him straight out of the fantasy he was living. Izuku made a distressed expression as he slowly slid the rose-colored glasses off his face to look at reality. The lights weren't as bright, and the fireworks didn't seem as dazzling anymore.

"Does that mean you'll stop overlapping on my assignments?" Izuku murmured.

"Yes," Katsuki said. He clenched his fists in his lap. "I'm moving to the far countryside to settle down for a long time. I, uh, actually own a bit of property out there that I don't use. I was going to set up in that town. It's quiet. Safe. Y'know, normal."

Normal.

That word anchored Izuku back to his world. He stared at Katsuki and viciously understood they were not the same. They did similar jobs, but Katsuki basked in the light of free will while Izuku did not. Izuku's heart broke in half when he weighed out every likely outcome. Each scenario he ran through his head landed at the same terrible ending.

"…We're never going to see each other again after this. Are we?" Izuku whispered.

The Ferris wheel began its descent down and so did Izuku's heart.

Katsuki's face crumbled and he quickly said, "I mean you could—"

Katsuki stopped his words.

Izuku waited.

And waited.

He waited the same excruciating way he waited for that year in Tokyo. But the extension never came. His shoulders slumped when he realized he was stupid for thinking Katsuki would offer him to come visit him. He felt even stupider for thinking that would even be *possible*.

Even if Katsuki did extend the offer—how would Izuku ever sneak around Tomura to go see an outsider?

Quickly, the cart began to feel suffocating when neither of them talked. Izuku tried to suppress the tears that were coming on, but it was as effective as a single man trying to stop a dam from breaking all by himself.

And when that dam inside of Izuku broke, everything rushed through.

They were finally reunited and now they were about to be ripped apart again. How did they squander all these years together not knowing it was each other by their side this whole time? Why was it only now, on Katsuki's last assignment, that they were finding out?

It wasn't fair.

None of this was *fair*.

ᔓᔓᔓ

The desire in his chest putrefied into bitterness the second they stepped off the Ferris wheel.

He could barely look at Katsuki or hold his hand. If he did either of those things, then what Katsuki said would be true. He didn't want to face the truth yet, not when he was supposed to be having fun. But all around him were couples laughing and kissing. They hugged each other and smiled with such pure, unreachable love.

All Izuku could do was gaze on with envy and he put his rose-colored glasses back on.

To avoid growing green with jealousy, Izuku found himself a lifeline by clinging to two things: denial and Mina.

Mina's energy was magnetic, joyful, and what Izuku needed right in the moment. He followed her lead and pretended to be as happy as she was. She made him laugh, giggle, and

told a bunch of jokes that Izuku never heard. It was a nice escape in a way Izuku never anticipated. Maybe in a different life they would have been the best of friends.

After a round of cotton candy shots in the carnival pop-up bar, Mina looked over her shoulder discreetly at their group. She grabbed Izuku's wrist and pulled him off to the side away from the rest of the group.

"Is everything okay, Hiroji?" Mina whispered quietly once they were alone.

"Yeah, everything is good," Izuku said quickly and entirely unconvincingly. His voice was several octaves higher than usual, and he could tell Mina didn't buy it. "Why do you ask?"

Mina cradled his hand softly with hers. "You've just been on edge it seems like. Did something happen on the Ferris wheel?"

Women's intuition. It was never wrong, and he had Himiko to thank for teaching him that lesson. He decided to weave in the truth to avoid being caught in a lie.

"While we were on the Ferris wheel, Taro told me he got a new job offer," Izuku said, thinly veiling the truth. "The location is…far. I worry about not seeing him much when he takes it. I-I feel like he's going to forget me."

Mina leaned in and hugged him tightly. "You're not forgettable at all Hiroji and Taro loves you very much."

Izuku wished that were true.

Then suddenly, Mina gasped like she had an idea. She pulled back and flashed him the brightest grin in the world.

"Oh! You know what you should do!" She exclaimed. "You two should get married again!"

Izuku rapidly blinked out of his daze. "H-Huh?"

Mina grinned wider. "Sometimes Ei and I go through some rough patches. Whenever we do, we get married again to remind ourselves where our center is. We've been married in twelve countries now with the same vows."

Izuku was very *very* surprised to learn that Japan's #1 happy go lucky couple experienced rough patches. But there was comfort in knowing their bond was as strong as they were and they always sought ways to keep it solid.

"That's very sweet of you two to do," Izuku said.

"You and Taro should do it," Mina pushed. "Trust me, it works wonders. There's even a marriage booth here you two could go to!" She jutted her head to the window of the bar.

Izuku peaked out of the window and there it was. In pink and yellow cursive font, the words "Marriage Drive Thru" sat with sparkling pink hearts blinking on and off. Each letter was

encased by a row of lightbulbs that dazzled against the night sky, beckoning everyone to come inside and a long line of couples shuffled around the corner.

Izuku nervously laughed it off. “I’ll consider it.”

Of course he didn’t. It wasn’t a real solution to their problem, so he didn’t think about it further.

ᔓᔓᔓ

As the night went on, Mina took it upon herself to make sure Izuku forgot his sadness.

She eagerly led him back to the bar and pounded back vodka shot after vodka shot like a champ. Right next to her in perfect sync was Eijirou and afterwards they encouraged their whole group to gather on the twinkling dance floor. Izuku danced up and down to the rhythm of the songs until bliss finally won against sadness.

He kept dancing and drinking, fully desperate to drown his sorrows even more.

Time slipped by him. He hadn’t kept track of his alcohol intake by mistake and his lethal guard was brought down by the weight of the emotions in his chest that he was unfamiliar with. He never felt sorrow this big, and as a result it took a toll on him.

The minutes passed accompanied by an egregious amount of alcohol and Izuku’s vision swayed.

He giggled entirely out of control as he chased the warm feeling in his stomach when Jirou hugged him. He took one more shot with the encouragement of Inasa who pinched his cheek.

His thoughts started to swarm together like a prism of light. Then he took one look at Katsuki and found himself lost again. Katsuki was sitting off to the side, not dancing. He was wrapped in the shadows staring at him with a crestfallen expression.

Now all Izuku could see was young, skinny Katsuki who was shivering in the cold without a jacket.

Like always, he went to him. Izuku tried to walk over to Katsuki and his whole vision blurred. He said some words he didn’t remember and pouted. He heard Katsuki’s voice go in and out and saw the glint of their wedding bands.

Suddenly, Katsuki carefully used both hands to slide the rose-colored glasses on top of Izuku’s head.

Izuku saw Katsuki plainly, and he faced the truth he didn’t want to. In two days, they would separate again, possibly forever, and that would be the final chapter for their story. Izuku stared at Katsuki longingly. He mourned all the memories they didn’t have a chance to create.

He interlaced their fingers and pulled himself close to Katsuki.

“You make me happy in a terrible way,” Izuku gently confessed.

Izuku leaned all the way into the only person he ever wanted. His head bopped with drunkenness as he rested their warm foreheads together.

After that, it all became a blur.

Mina came back over, insisting that she buy them one more round, and Shouto and Jirou were both pink in the face from drunken laughter. Inasa was patting some of the sweat off his body in the warm room with a pink napkin. So much was happening around them, but all Izuku could think about was Kacchan.

Suddenly the next thing Izuku knew was that they were dancing together.

They were in the middle of the room as everything swirled and bent out of shape. Izuku looked up at Katsuki and saw the boy he used to know. He did the one thing he wanted to do ever since he found him.

He hugged Katsuki tightly and slowly Katsuki embraced him back. They leaned into each other as they used one another for support. Katsuki’s cinnamon musk blanketed him and Izuku took it upon himself to wrap his arms around Katsuki’s neck.

He didn’t want to let go.

He dug his fingers into Katsuki’s shoulders.

He *couldn’t* let go.

The last thing Izuku remembered was staring at the words ‘Marriage Drive-Thru’ outside of the window.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Ninth Day in Paradise

The most wonderful dream came to Izuku that night.

It was painted like Van Gogh’s *Starry Night* but with bright pinks, purples, and reds. All around him were tiny hearts as melodic church bells rang in the background. He was standing at an altar in the sky with Katsuki hand in hand as they recited the same beautiful vows they made when they were kids. After they said ‘I do’ they shared a kiss so passionate doves began singing in falsetto and it rained down white rose petals from the sky.

Then with all the delicateness of a sledgehammer, Izuku’s dream was shattered into tiny fragments as he was thrust back into reality.

Suddenly he was cold, shivering, and his head felt like it was run over by a steamroller. Izuku heard a deep groan of disgust as he tried to blink his eyes open.

“Katsuki?” Izuku groggily called out, recognizing that sound of grouchiness. “Are you awake?”

“Yeah, I’m up,” Katsuki said with new hoarseness.

Izuku peered around the all too bright room to see Katsuki was in the bed with the same clothes as yesterday. Then he looked down at himself to see the same. His shirt was unbuttoned slightly and only one of his socks was missing.

Izuku groaned as he struggled to figure out why he was even wearing a sock. He wore *flats* last night.

“Do you remember what happened yesterday after the bar by any chance?” Katsuki muttered.

At this, Izuku sat up all the way. He tried to think and all he could remember was Mina shoving drinks in his face and dancing with Katsuki. After that, there was nothing but a black hole staring back at him.

“No,” Izuku grumbled tiredly. “I blacked out when Mina gave me my fourth shot of vodka and some fruity sounding drink. I had no clue they would be drinkers like that. Their tolerance is higher than anything I’ve ever seen.”

“Yeah. Leave it up to the fitspo couple to be extreme rage machines,” Katsuki grumbled. “Fucking pink and red lunatics.”

Izuku mumbled in agreement, grabbed his head, and plugged in his dead phone.

Katsuki made him extraordinarily stupid, Izuku noted. This was the first time he ever blacked out on a mission, and he felt sticky and disgusting for doing so.

He prayed on Hiryu’s grave that they didn’t let their real names slip.

Izuku squinted as he looked at the lock screen on his phone that was decorated with a picture of him and Katsuma. He tiredly sifted through his pictures folder to piece together what happened. He came across several blurry images of him and Mina mostly, and some sloppy shots of him and Katsuki holding up their wedding rings together under pink lights.

But Izuku came to a halt when he noted the background of the last picture. He zoomed in with two fingers and saw how the set up was the same church from his dream.

Izuku’s nose scrunched in confusion.

“Izuku…” Katsuki suddenly called his name from across the room.

Izuku peered towards his faux husband to see Katsuki standing there holding a small piece of paper in his hands. His eyes were wide with shock as if someone told him someone else died.

“Why the *fuck* does this marriage certificate say Bakugou Izuku and Bakugou Katsuki?”

Katsuki whipped his head to him and turned around the paper.

Izuku's eyes bulged at the bold lettering that said, 'Official Marriage'. He stared at the paper in front of him and the pretty blue ribbon that was stamped at the top with a golden emblem.

"Maybe it's not real," Izuku said easily because it *couldn't* be real.

"What the hell do you mean it's not real?" Katsuki snapped back. "It looks real as shit, Izuku. It even has the official stamp of Nago, Okinawa on it and says, 'marriage is legally recognized in the country of Japan'—and it has our goddamn government names on it."

Katsuki sat down on the edge of the bed, put his head in his hands, and then tossed Izuku the piece of paper.

Izuku wearily picked it up, and the longer he inspected the piece of paper, it did seem more official than he liked to believe. The neatness of it was something only found with government documents and that for sure was the official stamp of Nago, Okinawa.

Izuku began sweating slightly.

"I-It could be one of those fake marriage thingys!" Izuku reasoned.

Plenty of carnivals had fake Marriage booths. This was totally something fake. But then he noted the fake surname 'Bakugou' that was tacked on and was a bit more relieved.

"W-We should go find out where we got this from—it might not even be legally binding," Izuku rushed to say.

Katsuki scowled. "And if it fucking is?"

Izuku's face twisted in confusion. He didn't utter a word as he glanced between Katsuki and the piece of paper as if it was obvious.

"I-It can't be," Izuku spoke at a very slow pace. He bored his eyes into Katsuki because there was *no way*— "Your surname isn't actually Bakugou, is it? I thought that was fake."

"Of course it's my real surname. Why would I lie about that?"

Izuku's heart dropped, and he stared at Katsuki in horror.

"But why would you use your real surname for an assignment?" Izuku hissed. "Th-That's plain reckless and extremely poor undercover behavior. I don't ever reveal my real surname or first name on assignments—"

"—Look, the surname thing, sure. I probably should've checked in with a fake one," Katsuki quipped unhappily. "But, in my fucking defense, I figured this would be a one and done type of assignment: a bullet in that scummy bastard's skull from a rooftop in the dead of night and then I would leave. I didn't anticipate I would get up close and personal with the son of a bitch. And neither did my supervisor—but here we fucking are."

Izuku sat in disbelief at how badly Katsuki was trained.

He checked into a resort where he was going to *kill* someone using his *real* surname? He couldn't understand the sheer recklessness of that. But worse he couldn't comprehend the fact that if that was Katsuki's real last name…

…Then that meant…

Izuku stared at the name 'Bakugou Izuku' in a new, horrifying light.

He clutched the roots of his hair and held back a scream.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Much to Izuku's dismay, the surprises didn't stop there.

When he went to the bathroom, he found his entire chest and neck covered in hickies. Worse, it seems like drunk Katsuki did the hickies in the shape of a sloppy heart, with an extra emphasis on one above his right nipple.

Izuku groaned loudly as he examined his tender skin.

He couldn't decide if he was angrier about Katsuki's last name *actually* being Bakugou or if he couldn't remember getting his first hickey.

Why did nothing ever work out in his favor?

ᔓᔓᔓ

By the time they made it to breakfast, Izuku was sweating through his shirt. He told himself that there was no chance the marriage certificate was real because that would require them to be so stupid that a new definition of the word "morons" would have to be made.

He tried to keep his smile pinned neatly on his lips, but it was hard when their Paradise Crew told them what transpired last night. Not only was Izuku's choking kink tossed out in the open, but it seemed like Katsuki thought his ass was nice—which was news to him.

But much to their relief, it seemed like their drunken selves didn't spill their real identities.

Instead, drunk Izuku and Katsuki simply wandered off somewhere after mentioning that they needed to get married again. Which then triggered a memory in Izuku's head. He remembered smiling at Katsuki and leading him out into the night. Then quietly in the back of his mind, he remembered what Mina said before he blacked out.

"You two should get married again!"

Izuku's heart plummeted into his stomach. Oh. Oh no.

"And where did we go exactly?" Katsuki asked.

“To the Marriage Drive Thru at the carnival,” Jirou answered simply.

Izuku wanted the ground to swallow him whole.

ɯɯɯ

When they arrived at the Marriage Drive Thru it was like standing in front of the doors of hell. Izuku just never thought they would be colored pink.

They walked in and it was something straight out of a comedy movie. The plastic chapel was a bootleg version of what was in his dream with trash everywhere. With the help of alcohol this place seemed like a magical scene from a movie, but now in plain daylight it was clearly cheap and reeked of nicotine.

They walked in, found the owner whose name was Yasuo and quickly cut straight to business.

It was the worst-case scenario.

“All marriages done here are as official as any other marriage sealed elsewhere,” Yasuo told them as if he was offended. He turned his nose and mustache up at them as he crossed his arms. “We use a civil officiant and bring all the proper paperwork for convenience. All documentation is real and submitted to the city for permanent record every morning. If you’re married here, you’re married legally.”

Izuku forgot how to breathe as the shock immediately settled in.

Izuku began to turn a light purple in the face from lack of air and when he finally gasped for oxygen, he stumbled on the uneven ground. His knees buckled from sheer disbelief, and he quickly scrambled to grab onto a bench for purchase.

The pounding in his head tripled as their screw up came crashing down.

They were married.

Legally.

Everything twisted on its head. All Izuku could feel was Tomura preemptively breaking his nose.

He gagged as he felt this morning’s breakfast moonwalk itself back up his throat. Izuku quickly slapped his hand over his mouth and held his stomach. He was going to hurl then and there on the dingy pink carpet from stress.

“Is there a problem?” Yasuo asked. “If you would like, I could show you the tape from the wedding. For legal purposes, we document all weddings that happen here and then give every couple a copy for sentimental reasons. But, uh, I remember you two didn’t exactly wait for me to give you your copy.”

Izuku finally gathered courage to look at Katsuki.

Katsuki's face was paler than usual, and he was holding his forehead in disbelief. Katsuki's eyes wearily turned to him and suddenly, guilt rocked into Izuku's core. There was no doubt in Izuku's mind that Katsuki hated him now.

Izuku bit his lip and looked back at the owner.

"S-Sure," Izuku said in a whisper.

ᔓᔓᔓ

In Izuku's wildest dreams, he always wanted to have the perfect romantic wedding.

There would be white roses everywhere and an orchestra playing The Dance of The Love Birds in the background as he walked down an aisle made of glass that was perched above clear, running water. Flowing down from above would be hundreds of pink and yellow lilies as he marched forward to meet his true love.

But always in the back of his mind the person waiting at the end of the aisle would be Kacchan.

Which is why this tape was something surreal to witness.

He watched the flat screen TV, still in shock, as he and Katsuki stumbled on the screen drunk. They were clutching each other's hands endearingly and kept the other one steady. The camera focused in and out and then zoomed in on them shifting through a brown trunk of costume attire.

Izuku watched himself pick out a red bowtie and then watched Katsuki pick a green one. They pointed to the stained bowties, then to their shining wedding rings and snickered happily. Both were too drunk to tie their bowties properly—but neither of them seemed to care as they laughed.

Then Izuku watched himself reach for a white wedding veil, giggle slightly, and then don it on himself like a crown.

"Do I look pretty?" The Izuku on the screen slurred through his drunken speech.

The TV Katsuki nodded eagerly and stared at him in a way Izuku always imagined Kacchan would if they were ever reunited.

"The fucking prettiest."

They walked up hand in hand towards the aisle with a man who was dressed in black slacks and a blue and purple Hawaiian print shirt. Offbeat wedding music played from somewhere and Izuku could identify the tune as the clichéd 'Here Comes the Bride' melody.

They stopped in front of the Civil Officiant holding hands and gazing into each other lovingly. It was here Katsuki lowered his head as if he couldn't bear to witness what was to come on the tape.

But Izuku couldn't look away.

He watched as they signed several disclaimers and waivers. Then the Civil Officiant started reciting the magical words to bind them to each other. They were beautiful words Izuku had listened to and read a hundred times over in different media.

Now, he was watching himself listen to the words with hearts in his eyes. He was starring in a romantic movie with a love interest he had dreamed about for *years*. It should be a dream come true to see himself inserted in what was always a poor coping mechanism for his dull life.

But there was not an ounce of happiness inside of him witnessing this.

"You may now say your vows," the Officiant said.

Katsuki furrowed his brows and returned his eyes back to the screen.

"I promise to always come back to you, darling," the Katsuki on the screen said seriously. He gripped Izuku's hands tightly in his and slightly wobbled with a plastered grin. "I'll find my way back to you, again and again and again. I promise to always be by your side and I'll fucking kill anyone who gets in the way of us."

The officiant gave Katsuki a weary glance at the casual mention of murder. But to Izuku it felt like a love poem because it was so uniquely Katsuki. Izuku saw himself stare at Katsuki with hope, and he leaned into him tenderly.

"And I promise to always come back to you too," Izuku watched himself say. "I'll always find my way back to you."

"Promise?" Katsuki whispered desperately.

The drunk, unfocused gaze in their eyes sobered for that split moment. Everything slowed as Izuku watched them look at each other. It was then that the marriage didn't feel like a mistake, but rather a long time coming, and it was bizarre how genuine it quickly came across.

"I promise, Kacchan." Izuku stared back at him with equal gentleness. "I missed you. I'm so happy we found each other again just like we said we would."

"With that, do you, Bakugou Katsuki, take Mamushi Izuku to be your lawfully wedded husband?" The Officiant on screen asked. He glanced between the two men like he was witnessing something pure.

"I do," the Katsuki on screen said.

The officiant turned to Izuku with a smile. “And do you, Mamushi Izuku, take Bakugou Katsuki to be your lawfully wedded husband in return?”

“Of course, I do,” Izuku laughed lightheartedly. “Kacchan has always been my husband.”

“Then I now pronounce you Bakugou Katsuki and Bakugou Izuku!” The officiant said happily.

Izuku clenched his jaw when tears pricked at his eyes. He watched his first kiss from the third party.

It was something divine.

The solemn yearning in Izuku’s heart became stronger as the TV Katsuki tenderly cradled his face. They kissed each other like nothing else mattered as their eyes fluttered closed.

His eyes began to burn from not blinking.

The drunken Izuku was a carefree version of himself that didn’t seem held back by the shadowy strings orchestrating his life. He looked like he didn’t fear Tomura as he embraced Katsuki.

Any other time Izuku would have been appalled to know this sloppy, cheap marriage was how he was hitched. It went against every single fantasy he dreamed of, but instead he found himself transfixed and not because it was perfect, but rather because it was Katsuki who he was marrying.

Out of all Izuku’s wildest dreams, Katsuki really was the only one that mattered.

It was a damning realization because come tomorrow, they would be separated again, and this accidental marriage would be just that: an accident.

Izuku lowered his head away from Katsuki.

It suddenly hurt too much to look at him.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Talking about divorce was harder than it should’ve been.

There was an underlying feeling of wrongness about covering up this marriage, and it was evident in Katsuki’s attitude as well. They were finally reunited, and they were about to cut the cord once again, but this time willingly.

After they spoke about logistics, Katsuki gave him their marriage tape so he could destroy it. But Izuku wasn’t sure he could do that as he thought about what was on it. It was proof that maybe in another life Katsuki didn’t hate him. It was also evidence that his first adult kiss was with the one person he always wanted it to be with.

When they got back to the room, they danced around each other in an embarrassed tango.

They started to prepare for killing Moore by sharpening their blades and counting their bullets at the table in their room. Izuku methodically stacked his ammo and thought about which way to kill Moore with tender care. But as he put a bullet in each gun's chamber, it felt like striking away time on their limited minutes together.

"Do you want to talk about what happened on that tape?" Katsuki finally asked.

"Only that I'm sorry for getting drunk and suggesting that we get married," Izuku said quietly. He took out his knives and started carefully sharpening them. "I shouldn't have drunk so much, I should've cut myself off. I'm never that irresponsible on assignments usually—you probably hate me even more right now."

Katsuki let out a quick, sharp laugh. "Surprisingly, I don't think I hate you."

Izuku stopped sharpening his knife and raised his eyebrows.

"You don't?" Izuku asked.

"Naw, I don't think I do," Katsuki reaffirmed. He shrugged as he began to load the bullets in his handgun.

Butterflies of hope and surprise tickled the inside of Izuku's stomach. He searched Katsuki features for any signs of a lie. But all he found was an authentic, lovely grin staring back at him.

"Don't get me wrong, you're still a little shit," Katsuki said with a light chuckle. "But I'm glad we found each other again after Tokyo. Even before I knew it was you, I don't think I entirely hated you. I wanted to but I don't think I ever did. You were annoying and aggravating but—I didn't *hate* you. Besides, we *both* decided to get married. I signed that shit just as much as you did. We both fucked up, it's a shared responsibility."

Hearing that made Izuku suspend every belief he had of Katsuki.

This whole time he thought Katsuki hated him, but he didn't. It was enlightening to see his own emotions mirrored. It put their interactions over the last eight years into a new, softer light.

Izuku's expression grew more compassionate. "If I didn't know better, I would say you're getting soft on me."

"Don't fucking push it," Katsuki scoffed. He narrowed his eyes with a playful frown. "I said I don't hate you, doesn't mean I've forgotten eight years of flopped assignments because you shoved your gun in my goddamn face."

Izuku laughed lightly.

The awkwardness of the moment was easily brushed away. Izuku decided to simply enjoy their last day together.

Right as Izuku was about to go back to focusing, Katsuki suddenly moved his chair directly next to him. Izuku curiously peered at Katsuki, but Katsuki didn't lead on to anything as he shuffled in closely. Katsuki reached down and pulled Izuku's chair closer as well with a grin.

The heat from Katsuki's body rolled off his shoulders onto Izuku and their feet knocked together. Izuku thought it was a mistake, but when Katsuki purposefully locked their legs together and didn't move, Izuku's heart started to beat at a dangerous tempo yet again.

Katsuki really didn't hate him, after all this time.

As they continued preparing for the mission, Izuku couldn't help but steal shy glances at Katsuki. Katsuki did the same, but with a lot less shyness and he winked at Izuku as he leaned in closely.

Every now and then Katsuki would rock his legs, which would rock Izuku's. The gesture was so playful Izuku couldn't help but giggle as he cocked another one of his guns.

"I'm happy I got to spend this week with you, Katsuki," Izuku confessed quietly. There was a need inside of his chest that spread down his limbs as he looked at Katsuki. He yearned to reach out and hug the man in front of him so much it hurt. "It was nice getting to know you. As both Katsuki and Kacchan."

Katsuki warmly studied him, and he smirked.

"I'm glad I could spend this week with you as well." Katsuki leaned in slightly, locking their legs a tad bit more. "Weird how that all worked out, huh? Can't believe I'm a little disappointed this is our last night together."

Upon hearing those words, Izuku's heart clenched as if there was a hand around it.

It squeezed as he tried to take this moment to memorize Katsuki to take with him for his departure. But it didn't feel like it was enough. He wanted a kiss. He wanted his Kacchan. He wanted to be touched by Katsuki so badly it burned.

But more importantly, he wanted a say in what happened to his body.

Dangerous desire sparked under his belly. His eyes crawled up and down Katsuki's figure and stopped on his lips. Katsuki stared at him right back with the same amount of desire with those tempting eyes.

Izuku briefly considered Tomura and Chisaki.

He was torn between free will and obedience. Then he felt the ghost of Hiryu push him with both hands and awaken the spiteful side of him. It surged forward and showed him a flash of the drunken, carefree version of himself. He remembered the passionate, beautiful kiss on the tape and decided he was tired of watching movies. He was tired of reading books. He was tired of experiencing the things he wanted from the outside looking in.

Izuku wanted to live it.

He reached out and took a bite of the forbidden fruit.

Nothing else mattered as they were swept away under a tidal wave of dangerous flirtation. They danced around each other until their lips collided.

The kiss was everything Izuku thought it would be. He clung fiercely to Katsuki as their union became more and more intense. With every passing second, Katsuki breathed life back into the emotions Izuku had starved for oxygen.

They broke apart and Izuku took a deep breath.

Suddenly Izuku felt wholeheartedly *alive*.

Every broken feeling inside of Izuku pieced back together as Katsuki took him apart.

Katsuki worked him open with such delicious care that all his nerves washed away with every lick, suck, flick and kiss. Then Izuku's senses skyrocketed when Katsuki slowly pushed into him from behind. Inch by inch, Izuku was filled with all of Katsuki's needs.

Then it happened. A piece of Izuku that had never been touched before was found by Katsuki. Pleasure he never imagined bloomed inside of him and raked across his body. Izuku knew he made the right decision when Katsuki planted soft kisses along his nape and started to roughly fuck him with purpose.

In an instant, their bodies molded into a brutal erotic rhythm that was uniquely them. Delicate but feverish. Attentive yet dangerous. Every powerful thrust and ragged breath were perfectly in tandem with their twisted sonata.

Rapture seized him by the throat and Izuku became overwhelmed. His touch starved nerve endings were set ablaze as Katsuki brought him to the peaks of the heavens twice. Izuku didn't even know that was *possible*.

Then his whole body violently shook when he peaked a third, impossible time with intoxicating ecstasy at the same time Katsuki came inside of him. With their synchronized orgasms came the final blow resuscitating all his emotions.

One by one every single forgotten emotion inside of Izuku toppled over each other in a stampede.

He sobbed instantly as his vision went white.

Katsuki immediately wrapped his arms around him, pulling him against his chest. Loud sobs tore through Izuku's throat as he leaned on Katsuki for support. He blinked rapidly, unsure of what was happening when his body convulsed with countless ripples of euphoria.

"I got you, darling," Katsuki reassured. He tightened his grasp as Izuku gave one more full body tremor. "There you go, feel it all the way through you. You're doing *so* fucking good."

Izuku keened at the praise and his cock spurted a dribble of cum once more. Katsuki kept going, offering up sweet nothings in Izuku's ear as he became doused in overstimulation.

He was sweet. Kacchan was so *sweet*.

“I’m so lucky I got to have you like this. Thank you,” Katsuki whispered. Izuku closed his eyes and another wave of pleasure traveled down from his head to his chest and landed at his toes. “I’m going to kiss you all damn night.”

Izuku wanted that too. His toes curled as he gasped and pushed back on the cock inside of him. His knees gave out but he didn’t want this beautiful feeling to end.

With gentle care, Katsuki lowered them on the mattress as he slid out of Izuku. He carefully cradled Izuku and stroked his hair affectionately. Lovely kisses peppered across his temple, his face, his cheeks. Izuku soaked up each one as he slowly came down. He leaned into the warm arms embracing his body and relaxed fully.

As he laid there breathless and dazed, he thought about how sex was more intense than he ever imagined. It was as if he had given more than just his body to Katsuki. He had offered up pieces of his soul that he would never get back.

They were gone along with his eighty-million-dollar virginity.

ɯɯɯ

They lay there under the covers after they came down exchanging kisses and touches. Izuku thought he would feel the weight of regret, but he didn’t.

Katsuki was the right person, he always was.

Katsuki played with his hair and counted his freckles, kissing each one. They made no move to look at the clock or acknowledge their limited time together. Izuku’s hand explored Katsuki’s body as he traced some of his veins and he kissed a scar above Katsuki’s heart.

Katsuki lifted the palm of Izuku’s hand and left a tiny kiss above the scar there.

With that simple motion, there was a line crossed. They waltzed right over it and didn’t dare look back. Whatever barriers were up between them came tumbling down as if they both took twin sledgehammers to the wall and broke it into tiny fragments.

Izuku measured his hand against Katsuki, and their matching rings glimmered in the soft moonlight together. Izuku realized they could take these off now—but then Katsuki slowly curled his fingers, intertwining their hands.

The gesture was so pure it made Izuku’s heart sink further into yearning.

“Thank you,” Katsuki whispered into the dark room. He stroked Izuku’s freckled skin with his thumb, and Izuku relished the coarseness he might never feel again. “I meant to tell you that earlier. Thank you for being there for me that year in Tokyo. It means a lot to me. You —” Katsuki sucked in a deep breath. “You saved me, when no one else was there.”

Izuku smiled back at him.

“You saved me too.”

ᔓᔓᔓ

Last Day in Paradise

The alarm went off for their mission to begin at exactly 01:00 sharp.

There was a dark emotion in Izuku that took control now that they needed to switch back into lethal mode. The vacation of his dreams was done with and now it was time to check back into reality.

Their plan was straight forward: Get to the headquarters on Ie Island, kill Moore, and stage the scene to look like a twisted love affair gone wrong.

Afterwards, they would change into hiking clothes and go to the hiking area on Ie Island. They would act as though they were there enjoying some early morning hiking when the police raid hit since there would be little time between killing Moore and checking out of the hotel for good.

When Izuku turned to Katsuki, he couldn’t stop himself from feeling concerned. He looked at Kacchan up and down and watched as he dressed himself. The urge to straighten out his shirt and comb his thick hair for him tingled at his fingers. He followed it and smoothed out a wrinkle in Katsuki’s shirt with shaking limbs.

But Katsuki quickly steadied his shaking hands and reminded him that he didn’t have to worry about him anymore.

They set off for their mission knowing it was the final time they would be together.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Once they made it to the headquarters every hair on Izuku’s body stood up tall. An eerie feeling settled in like spiders lurking underneath his skin. Izuku almost forgot what it was like to be in the presence of true evil after a mere ten days.

They easily cut their way through the sea of bodyguards and were able to execute their plan of attack perfectly until one particular guard swiped at Izuku’s chest. He moved a slight second short and the fabric of his body suit was sliced open. The flap leaned forward to expose his mark.

Izuku forgot about his mark somehow. He tacked up the piece of cloth without much thought.

While Izuku put down the bodyguards, Moore and Koizumi tried to flee into a panic room like cowards. Katsuki was able to land two bullets into Koizumi, dropping him to the ground. But he was not quick enough to stop Moore in his tracks.

Without sparing a single glance, Moore ran away and left behind Koizumi.

Izuku could see the bitterness rake across Koizumi's face when he pinned him down with his foot.

Katsuki chased after Moore but came back empty handed. They deduced that Koizumi must've known where he was, but he was a tough shell to crack. The power of love, Izuku figured. It would make you nearly die for the person.

They tied up Koizumi in a chair and began to interrogate him. It went on without a blip until the slashed part of Izuku's body suit fell forward.

The number 217 was on full display.

Izuku quickly slapped the fold back up, but it was too late.

"Wait—*that tattoo*," Koizumi whispered, sounding astonished. His eyes inched wider and wider by the second with recognition. "I recognize that type of tattoo. You're from the Viper Academy. Aren't you?"

Izuku almost put a bullet in Koizumi's mouth out of reflex. But then remembered they still needed him.

"Tell us where Moore went," Izuku hissed dangerously. Izuku's nostrils flared, he cocked his gun and pointed it directly at Koizumi's face. "*Now*. I won't ask again."

"What number are you? I didn't get a good look," Koizumi said lazily. He seemed not to care that he was staring down the barrel of a loaded gun. "200s I think I saw? Was it above 250 or below?"

"His number...?" Katsuki whispered carefully.

Horror sunk into Izuku like a thousand knives when Koizumi began chuckling like a mad man in the chair. Katsuki turned to him, perplexed at what was happening and Izuku felt like his whole world was going to fall apart.

He tried to shut Koizumi up but was stopped by Katsuki grabbing the barrel of his gun.

Then his worst nightmare came true when Koizumi revealed what kind of monster he was.

"If that's his number, then his mother sold him to Peter when he was under the age of five because she couldn't handle taking care of a child, needed money, and wanted a discreet way to continue on with her life."

Every word was a razor blade skating across his skin.

"At the time, we were helping parents who had some unfortunate life circumstances start over by getting rid of children they couldn't or simply didn't want to take care of. Not all took the offer to give us their kids. But some did—seems like *his mother* did. Which means he's the 217th child to be sold to the Viper Academy."

Izuku wearily looked at Katsuki who didn't look at him at all.

Katsuki tensed up like he was disgusted and Izuku wanted to rewind time and cut Koizumi's tongue out. The closure he had gotten from their last night together was shattered by the same man who ruined his life before.

Izuku's hands began shaking.

"What? Is this news to you?" Koizumi taunted Katsuki. The twisted man was smiling past the blood trickling from his nose. "You must not be from the Viper Academy then, you're far too stunned. But I'm curious, you two are killing partners and you didn't know he was groomed for this?"

Katsuki whirled his head and he looked ghastly.

Tears were threatening to spill any second from Izuku's eyes as his shaking grew worse.

Quickly, Izuku snapped out of it. He violently snatched his gun out of Katsuki's hold and took a large step backwards, unable to meet Katsuki's eye out of shame. His skin began crawling as if he was made of dirt and worms were weaving in and out of his pores. He was filth. Katsuki knew he was nothing more than a killing machine and *freak*.

He snapped his mask off his face when it felt like he was in that glass box back in Tokyo.

"Izuku. You're shaking," Katsuki whispered.

Katsuki turned Izuku around and forced them to meet eye to eye. Shame gnawed at Izuku's stomach lining when the red eyes he'd grown to admire so much were looking at him so differently. He wasn't Deku now. He wasn't even *Izuku*. He was something else and the horror in Katsuki's face was indisputable.

The tears that were holding on for dear life spilled down Izuku's cheeks.

"S-Sorry. I—" Izuku started. He stared around the room, struggling not to lose it. "G-Give me a minute to re-balance and I'll be fine."

"Is what he said true?" Katsuki asked slowly. His grip on Izuku's shoulders tightened when Izuku couldn't answer. "Tell me it's not fucking true," he desperately whispered through his gritted teeth and his nostrils flared. "You chose this life…*right*? You weren't forced into it?"

Izuku tried to pull away, but Katsuki dug his fingers into Izuku and forced their eyes to meet.

"*Izuku*. Answer me," Katsuki commanded forcefully.

"I—I didn't want you to know."

Izuku's voice shattered as he clenched his teeth.

He hung his head low as his whole life flashed before his eyes.

He thought about all the cherished moments he held with Katsuki from Tokyo to now. Dancing in front of the violinist to singing in the park as kids. He thought about how they

slowly danced on the boat and their shared moment watching the sunset. He thought about all the things he wanted to stay haloed by innocence. But now it was all tainted because Katsuki knew what kind of terrible person he was.

Izuku hesitantly glanced up expecting the worse—

—and Katsuki's expression was something fearsome.

His pupils were restricted down into tiny dots to the point his eyes were only pools of blood red. Underneath the alarm lights, the hue of scarlet eyes appeared deeper and far more sinister. His lips were curled back, and he bared his teeth like some sort of animal.

A chill raked down Izuku's spine.

"...Go sit down until you stop shaking," Katsuki suddenly instructed a little too calmly.

Izuku was apprehensive. He backed up a bit, and Katsuki nodded at him in the most reassuring way that contradicted his homicidal gaze. Izuku slowly eased down in one of the luxe chairs in the room and stared at Katsuki. He was unsure of what was about to happen.

He followed Katsuki's tense shoulders as he grabbed a baseball bat off the wall. He tested the weight of the object in his hands and nodded as if he was satisfied. He swung the heavy item over his shoulder and all the disgust Izuku thought he would receive was directed towards Koizumi.

Katsuki's sharp eyes cut into Koizumi and the silver chain around his neck gleamed under the dark red lights. He began antagonizing Koizumi in a way Izuku never saw him do before.

Then a sliver of truth was revealed that Izuku never expected.

"I'm a fucking sadist at the end of the day," Katsuki admitted as he held the end of the bat to Koizumi's throat. "I've worked in this field for nearly ten years. It's hard not to enjoy it a tiny bit—*especially* when it's scum like you. Hell, I'm so cruel I'm sure you might've heard of me."

"No." Koizumi leered. "I don't think I have heard of an arrogant, blond hitman."

Katsuki cocked his head. "The Scarlet Eyed Killer."

Then like a switch, recognition sparked along both Koizumi's and Izuku's faces.

Koizumi's age lines tightened when his eyes grew wide and there was a flood of disbelief then finally horror set in. Katsuki smirked maliciously and pushed the bat further into the pale neck.

"Ah. There it is—the *fear*," Katsuki mocked cruelly.

He applied more pressure until Koizumi choked.

Izuku stared on in extreme curiosity as he thought about that gruesome murder that occurred five years ago. The gutting and crucifixion of Imasuji Goto was no easy feat. It took a high level of skill, precision and callous depravity. And it was *Katsuki* who did it flawlessly. Right before his eyes, Izuku witnessed the boy from his childhood shape-shift from a hitman to a wanted serial killer in mere seconds.

Katsuki's inner demon crawled free like Koizumi's torture was about to be his playground.

"So, you have heard of me," Katsuki chuckled darkly when Koizumi began squirming. "I'm sure you know then, I'm the person gangsters request by name when they need someone handled and want them to fucking feel the agony in every single bone. I don't do the job without pain unless *instructed*."

Katsuki leaned down and smirked menacingly an inch away from Koizumi's face.

"And guess what? I wasn't fucking instructed to for this assignment."

Then it began. Swing after brutal swing with the metal bat rained down on Koizumi in a ferocious storm. Every time Katsuki connected the bat with flesh, he made sure to break bone and make it *hurt*. Sickening cracks reached Izuku's ears as he witnessed blood spray into the air. It was barbarous, drawn out, and a method of torture that would leave Koizumi in pain up until his last breath.

Izuku couldn't look away as Katsuki drank up Koizumi's cries like they were an ether.

Something inside Izuku rumbled as Koizumi began struggling and caved in.

All of the secrets spilled from Koizumi's filthy lips as he handed over Moore's location in the building. He told Katsuki about the master key in his pocket as he sobbed woefully. Izuku tilted his head as he watched Katsuki calmly dig in Koizumi's pants and take out the golden key.

He pocketed it away and sat down the bat calmly.

Like the predator he was, The Scarlet Eyed Killer circled Koizumi and stood behind him. Slowly, Katsuki unsheathed his blade. It shone with the kiss of death in the dim, red lighting of the room. Izuku's adrenaline spiked and his back straightened.

Katsuki placed a hand on Koizumi's shoulder to steady him as he pressed the blade at his throat.

"The murder or the suicide?" Katsuki asked Izuku.

A litany of desperate pleas erupted from Koizumi. He wheezed out his last words that were bargains for his life. Money. Women. Men. All things that didn't really belong to him and Izuku wondered if this is how he begged his mother to sell him as well. Izuku found deep satisfaction when Katsuki gripped Koizumi's hair. He yanked on it to keep him still as he held the sharpened blade into his bobbing throat.

"The suicide," Izuku whispered. "Let him have his tragic ending for his tragic love."

Katsuki smirked and Koizumi screamed more.

“I think that’s a perfect ending for his story, darling.”

Katsuki’s intense gaze never left him as he slit Koizumi’s throat.

Not once did he blink. Not once did Izuku look away.

Izuku held his breath when the spiteful Viridian Viper inside of him snaked up his throat. It was awoken by Katsuki’s demon and beckoned him to join. Crimson blood dripped from Koizumi’s throat like steady rain. It poured down his shirt and trickled onto his lap. The way his eyes rolled back was so sickly satiating to the point it shocked Izuku at how gratified he was to witness this.

After Katsuki finished dragging his blade across the leathery throat, he wiped his weapon clean with a single, precise swipe of his other gloved hand.

Katsuki kept his eyes trained on Izuku as he walked forward. His aura was several degrees below zero and his handsome face was twisted in violent protectiveness.

“Let’s go,” Katsuki growled. “And when we find the other bastard, you land a blade right in his heart.”

They found Moore, and Izuku did exactly that.

ɯɯɯ

When they finished setting the stage for the murder-suicide coup Izuku couldn’t escape Katsuki’s eyes.

Something in Katsuki shifted gears and he was looking at Izuku like he was breakable. There was so much pity. Too much of it for Izuku to handle.

Shame began to nest between his ribs again by the time the sun came out. He felt naked and exposed beyond reason when they made it out of headquarters and into the forest. The beautiful sun was a reminder that this vacation was over, and it ended with Katsuki knowing something he never was supposed to know.

Izuku began to break from all the toppling stress.

It rapidly seemed as if everything began to catch up with Katsuki too.

Out of nowhere Katsuki asked, “Why didn’t you tell me?” His voice was so hoarse and trampled with disappointment that Izuku didn’t recognize it. “Izuku, why didn’t you fucking *tell me*? I feel like a goddamn idiot. All this *time*.”

“You weren’t supposed to know,” Izuku whispered through his gritted teeth. “No one is supposed to know that.”

“But why not tell *me*?” Katsuki shot back, and Izuku didn’t have an answer.

Katsuki tried to rush forward and stop him, but Izuku simply yanked himself out of his grasp. He couldn't face Katsuki right now.

"Izuku, don't fucking do *that*!" Katsuki snapped as he began crying too.

After that it was a mess of tears, confessions, and shouts.

They melted back into the hurricane they were together, but it was upgraded into a typhoon. They pushed and pulled and Izuku felt all the emotions in his chest pour out like a raging river. He found himself expressing things he never thought he could. But of course—it came easy with Katsuki. Katsuki made him feel emotion so easily that it was as if an entire childhood of beating weakness out of him didn't occur.

"It doesn't matter if I was trafficked," Izuku shouted at the peak of their argument. "If police showed up at my door they're not going to let me go because of some sob story. They would think I'm better off dead because it's too late for me."

Katsuki's eyes softened yet again and suddenly Izuku couldn't bear to look at him.

It hurt. Why did it hurt?

"You're more than capable of being kind, Izuku. I'm living proof of that."

Those were the words that broke a fragile part of Izuku.

"I know." Izuku chuckled sadly and clutched above his heart. "A-And that's what's confusing. When I'm with you, I've never felt like I was pretending. In Tokyo, I cared for you so much I knew it was real. B-But, I lost it after you left. Then when we met in Vienna, even though I didn't know it was you—I felt a flicker for a while. I pitied you, and I hadn't pitied anyone for a long time until Vienna. A-And now, h-here in Okinawa, I feel like I actually lo—"

Izuku's words halted.

He grew sad. Ah. This is why this all hurts so much.

He loved Katsuki.

"…Why am I telling you this?" Izuku whispered distantly. "We're never going to see each other again. You're going to go live the normal life you deserve in the countryside and I'm going to go back to my family in Tokyo. I-It doesn't matter how I feel."

Katsuki reached out and tried to stop him, but Izuku took off deeper into the forest.

"Izuku, wait—*shit*," Katsuki cursed behind him and tripped on a root. "Izuku! Wait!"

"—No. I'm d-done." Izuku shook his head and walked further. "This is done. I-I can't keep looking at you. It's starting to feel like I'm torturing myself with something I'll never really *have*. W-We should part ways early, I promise I'll send you what you need for the divorce, but I c-can't do th-this. You weren't supposed to *know*—"

Katsuki rushed forward and grabbed him, but the touch was like hot coals against his skin.

Izuku struggled against Katsuki, and once again it all felt familiar. Familiar like the last eight years of assignments. Familiar like the rose garden. Familiar, like they always were a push and pull of desperate forces compelled towards each other. But in this instance, it was unfamiliar in the sense that for the first time, Katsuki seemed like he couldn't let go.

They stepped in tandem in the tussle, and part of the ground cracked under their weight.

It happened quicker than either of them could think.

Izuku gasped when the ground underneath his feet gave out. He slipped backwards uncontrollably, and Katsuki yelled in sync with him as he went toppling forward, breaking through the surface.

They were falling rapidly and dangerously.

Izuku yelled in fear as they were swallowed by absolute darkness. He clung to Katsuki as they went down and Katsuki clung to him too. The plummet into the shadows was full of terror until Izuku's back hit the ground with mind shattering pain.

The sound of bones snapping like twigs tore through the air.

Everything in Izuku's body lit on fire and he screamed in agony.

Izuku cried out in pain when he suddenly was now as broken physically as he was emotionally. His emotional condition only worsened when Katsuki immediately began to tend to him, and Izuku wanted to push him away but *couldn't*. He watched through bleary eyes as the man he loved behaved in a way as if he loved him back.

Katsuki quickly set his ankle and gave him a pain killer. He tried to wipe away the dirt on Izuku's tear stained face and every action felt like cruel torture to Izuku. He indulged in the fantasy of being loved by Katsuki, and now here he was: a deflowered fool madly in love and accidentally married.

Izuku resigned to his fate when Katsuki pulled him against his chest. He focused on his breathing to try to distract him from the blistering pain that was dramatically blooming all over his body.

He leaned against Katsuki for what might be the last time and Katsuki held him tightly.

"I should've come back," Katsuki's voice broke in two as Izuku held on to him. "I wish I fucking came back for you."

Izuku wished he did too. But he didn't say anything because he didn't want Katsuki to feel guilty.

"Do you have to go back?" Katsuki asked, his face twisted with desperation.

“I do.” Izuku shook his head, exhausted. “Someone will notice quickly if I’m missing. There’s not really another alternative, and it’s alright. I’ve accepted this, Katsuki. Anything you think of in the next ten minutes, I have already thought of in the last twenty-five years of my life. It’s all the same path in the end.”

Information that usually could not get tortured out of him began to flow from Izuku.

He told him about the Governor of Tokyo and Moore’s connections with The Viper Academy. He even told Katsuki about his failed attempt at escaping when he was a child. He spilled on how they were raised to be cold and detached from the outside world and how he was defective in his family’s eyes.

With every word, a weight lifted from his chest.

Izuku suddenly felt light while lying in Katsuki’s arms. He looked up at the sun that was seated in the sky sadly and closed his eyes.

Katsuki lifted a hand to stroke his hair. He did this over and over to the point he calmed Izuku down. The calloused fingers tenderly grazed his cheeks and it nearly seemed like Katsuki loved him too.

Izuku closed his eyes as Katsuki continued to soothe him.

ɯɯɯ

Eventually, the police raid occurred.

When the Special Assault Team infiltrated the warehouse, they found a bloodied scene that puzzled them. After closer investigation, and interrogating the trafficking victims inside, it was chalked up to a sudden coup to take the White Dove business in a fit of passion and jealousy by Minoru Koizumi.

Izuku could barely keep his eyes open as he was overcome with pain both inside his heart and outside of it. They were still stuck in the pit. He felt Katsuki place a hand over his rapidly beating heart and he stayed still in order not to agitate his wounds further.

In the distance, the distinct sirens of the Special Assault Team inched closer.

Izuku blinked his eyes open and ignored the throbbing of his ankle. Katsuki immediately began screaming for help at the top of his lungs, playing the role of the distraught husband. Izuku almost thought it was real for a moment with the way Katsuki sobbed while screaming out in concern.

He’s gotten good at playing a doting husband, Izuku noted.

They were found by Shouto and eventually rescued from the pit. Katsuki hoisted him up in his arms effortlessly and Izuku allowed himself to be carried. He rested his head against Katsuki's chest and listened to the rapid beating of his heart. In the background Izuku heard

police dogs, people crying, and could see the blinking blue and red sirens clashing with the bright and sunny forest.

He drowned out all the commotion as he focused on Katsuki's pulse.

Izuku leaned in closer to Katsuki and waited patiently for their final moment to come.

What a horrible way to end their reunion, Izuku thought bitterly.

"Okay, you can get medical attention here," Shouto said to Katsuki when they arrived at a medical tent. "Don't talk to anyone you see; we're investigating the crime scene."

Katsuki nodded like he didn't know what was happening. "Of course."

Izuku stayed quiet, not even acknowledging Shouto's presence. He found himself silently envying Shouto as he thought about how both their vacations were over for good. But unlike Izuku, Shouto got to go home to his real husband and live a normal life.

"Is he okay?" Shouto whispered.

"He's just—" Katsuki paused and thought about his words. "He's just in pain."

"I'm fine," Izuku finally spoke up. He snapped out of his daze, and turned to Shouto with a plastic, apologetic smile. "Sorry for being so quiet, my ankle is throbbing and it's hard to focus."

"No need to apologize for being hurt," Shouto said with a kind smile.

Izuku wished that were true because the second Tomura saw his injuries, he would be apologizing profusely.

Quickly a paramedic came up to them, gesturing with his hand to others in the background. They pointed to Izuku's ankle, and a white stretcher was brought out. Anxiety flushed through Izuku's veins when he understood this was their final moment. The second Katsuki put him down on that stretcher he would go back to Tokyo, they would get the divorce, and everything would continue in his life.

If this was a week ago, Izuku would have easily thought he'd see Katsuki again. But now he knew that wasn't going to be the case.

"Sir, can you place him down on the stretcher please?" The paramedic asked.

Katsuki didn't respond. He blankly stared at the stretcher as if it was a boobytrap.

"Um, Taro?" Shouto called out Katsuki's fake name.

That snapped Katsuki out of his daze. He wearily glanced at everyone. It clicked. Izuku could see the anxiousness pouring off Katsuki in waves. His faux—no. Not faux anymore. His *real* husband held him tighter in his arms and it was obvious he didn't want to be separated either.

“You have to put me down on the stretcher now,” Izuku said quietly. His hand gently caressed Katsuki’s shoulder as he looked up at him. “You have to let me go.”

Katsuki shook his head. “No.”

Izuku balked.

He reeled his head back and so did Shouto and all the paramedics. Izuku’s mouth dropped, and his ankle spiked with pain at that moment. He hissed at the throbbing burn when Katsuki held him a bit *too* tightly.

“No?” One paramedic said. Her face deeply frowned and looked between Katsuki and Izuku. “Sir, he needs medical attention right now—”

“—I mean, *fuck*, just hold on a damn minute,” Katsuki hissed. “I need to speak to my husband privately.”

Katsuki turned on his heel before any questions could be asked. Izuku was whipping his head between Katsuki and the medical tent, entirely disgruntled and in dire need of something other than Advil.

What was Katsuki *doing*? Izuku could do nothing but be carried far out of earshot of Shouto and everyone else around them. They were now on the edge of the chaos, still trapped in the crime scene tape. Katsuki finally stopped and then looked down at him with wild eyes.

“*Katsuki*?” Izuku hissed in a low whisper. “What are you doing? I’m in *pain*—”

“—Come back with me,” Katsuki said quickly before he could change his mind.

Shock, surprise, then finally sadness set in Izuku’s heart.

“I-I can’t do that,” Izuku whispered.

He thought about Tomura and could feel his brother’s grasp on him puppeteer his movements.

“Do you really think you can fucking work on assignments with as many broken bones you have right now?” Katsuki retorted. He was being pushy, holding onto Izuku uncomfortably tight like he might fade away. “What are you going to do about this, *hah*? Is your handler going to make you work through a broken ankle or some shit?”

“I do have sick leave believe it or not,” Izuku said with an edge. “I’m not treated like a slave. Injuries are frowned upon, but as long as I can prove I’m incapacitated, I’m allowed to have time to recover. I will just rest up before I get my next tasks.”

“Do you live alone?”

“Kind of, but what does that have to do with anything?”

“Is anyone going to help you while you recover?”

“Ye—” Izuku stopped.

Tomura would take care of him, yes. But he had a rule that for every broken bone Izuku acquired on a mission, he would break another in return to teach him a lesson in clumsiness. Izuku glanced down at his ankle, and he could feel that it was a bare minimum of at least four broken bones.

Suddenly, he wasn’t too sure he wanted Tomura to find out. Especially with the deal with Chisaki on the table.

“I-I’ll be fine,” Izuku muttered, curling into himself at the thought of his future punishment. “It’s not the first time I’ve broken a bone.”

“I can help,” Katsuki pressed on.

Izuku assessed Katsuki’s desperation wearily.

“Only until your ankle heals,” Katsuki quickly clarified. “I’m sure you’ll fuck it up worse if you have to do shit by yourself because you’re clumsy like that. I can take out the trash, clean, and all that junk.” Izuku tried to object but Katsuki spoke over him. “You need someone there to help you. You’re going to be on crutches, or in a wheelchair. You can’t just go fucking live alone for four months.”

Izuku stayed quiet.

His heart was hammering, and he was tempted once more by Katsuki in an impossible situation. He thought he would be satisfied with their one night together in this fake pink paradise, but Izuku somehow wanted more.

Then Katsuki held him closer and begged. “*Please*.”

Izuku was weak against Katsuki. He always was, and today was no different as he began trying to figure out a way to make Katsuki’s request come true. Could he disappear for four months? Was that a possibility?

Izuku considered it like it wasn’t insane.

“Let me return the favor and take care of you until your ankle is better,” Katsuki whispered. “Then we can go our separate ways. I promise.”

Izuku went from weary to wearily hopeful.

The longing inside of his chest called out for Katsuki and begged him to make it work. He thought about all the romantic novels and movies he watched and read. There was always a part where something would tear people away from each other. But it was overcome by the desire to make it work.

And this—it could work but it required Izuku to make an extremely dicey move.

“I-It would be risky for me to disappear that long,” Izuku muttered. “Especially with someone. Th-They can’t know about us. I could get in a lot of trouble for inappropriate copulation.”

“How risky would it be?” Katsuki asked.

“If they see me being friendly with someone, I risk termination.”

“I promise where we’re going would be isolated. You will be safe, no one will recognize you. It’ll just be me, you, and this plot of land with a garden and shit. It’s private.”

“It’s still pretty risky,” Izuku said. He suddenly remembered Aoyama and how he covered for him going to Spain once off the books two years ago. “B-But—I do have a favor I could call in, I suppose. One of my brothers owes me from a long time ago when I covered for him going out of range. He could cover for me going out of range this time.”

“Do it,” Katsuki said.

He thought about Tomura and Chisaki, but more so he thought about Katsuma. He still hadn’t come up with a plan to get him out and in a way, this would buy him more time. But it was a selfish motive too. He wanted to get to know Kacchan and understand who he was when they weren’t opposing forces. It was a big risk though if anyone ever saw them together—especially if Himiko did.

Their eyes met and Izuku could feel the bad decision stamp into his skin.

He decided to follow his heart.

“Okay,” Izuku said. He nodded his head, unsure but gradually smiled. “I’ll come back with you.”

Both of their hearts hammered at the highest tempo possible.

ɯɯɯ

The Night After Paradise

Izuku never would have guessed he’d be walking back into Tokyo with Kacchan. Much less never would he have thought Kacchan was the stranger who kept popping up in his life. If someone told him this, he probably would have thought they were on several types of drugs and brought them to a doctor.

But here they were, trotting down the crowded sidewalks of his hometown with him in crutches and Katsuki holding his bag. Tokyo appeared different now but somehow the same. The neon colors in the night scene illuminated with life and the car engines roared loudly. Clusters of bodies stacked together in a steady, fluid shuffle to whatever location everyone was off to in the late summer heat.

As they neared Hadeus, Izuku stopped short.

He cautiously peered at Katsuki's blond hair and red eyes.

There was no way he could bring him anywhere near his family after The Incident. He instructed Katsuki to stay out of sight and stay stationed in a cafe that was on the edge of Hadeus' boundaries. He tossed his bag over his shoulder with some struggle but managed as he limped his way into his skyscraper home.

Once inside Izuku took the elevator up to the penthouse level.

He hobbled down the hallway towards the double doors of his home. He was about to pull out his keys, but quickly recognized the sound of Tomura's footsteps coming towards the door from the inside.

Izuku held his breath and hastily shuffled around the corner out of sight. He pressed his back against the wall and looked up to the ceiling.

Tomura walked out of the penthouse with his three dogs barking loudly. Tomura sighed and shuffled his keys and his feet as he slammed the door.

"Yes, I should be hearing from Izuku soon, don't worry Chisaki," Tomura muttered while on the phone. "It seems like the Moore mission was completed with ease based on the news. I will get an update from Izuku soon as he comes and checks in."

Izuku held his breath as Tomura walked by.

The rowdy dogs were hogging all of Tomura's attention, luckily. They seemed hungry from the sounds of it, and Tomura walked off down the hall without noticing him. Once the elevator door dinged and Izuku heard the barking fade, he wobbled out of the shadows. He looked around and then glanced at the door.

He got inside quickly and knew he needed to work with haste.

He went straight for his room and packed his belongings. He switched out his clothes and stuffed everything to the brim. He packed about enough for a single month, but he assumed Katsuki had laundry wherever they were going off to hide.

After Izuku discreetly packed his bags, he snuck into Katsuma's room.

The lights were already off and Katsuma was neatly tucked into bed. The teddy bear in his arms told Izuku Aoyama was the one to put him down for the night. He limped over and studied his little brother's peaceful face. With delicate care, Izuku leaned down and kissed Katsuma on the forehead. Katsuma roused slightly and hugged his teddy bear tighter.

Part of Izuku wanted to wake him, but he knew that wouldn't be ideal.

He needed to sneak out quickly before Tomura noticed his presence.

Izuku crept down the halls with all the stealthiest he could manage on crutches. It was difficult. Every hobble he took was like sounding alarms this late at night, but he was able to pull it off with surprising ease.

He worked his way through the skyscraper to reach Aoyama's private suite.

He took a deep breath in and knocked.

Aoyama answered the door dressed in blue PJs holding a cup of coffee in his hand. He rubbed his eyes sheepishly and smiled weakly. His eyes landed on Izuku's injured leg and there was a bit of surprise in his face.

"Well, welcome home," Aoyama laughed. "I saw the news about what happened in Paradise, I guess you didn't make it out unscathed. Are you here to give a debrief? Tomura said he wanted you to wait until the morning to debrief with him."

Of course, Izuku thought bitterly.

Izuku cut straight to the chase. "I need to cash in the favor you owe me for when I covered for you going off the books to Spain that one time."

Aoyama frowned. He glanced down either end of the hallway and then pulled Izuku inside.

They quietly walked into Aoyama's suite that was decorated in navy blue. Izuku loved the various tech geek posters and how modern Aoyama's furniture was. They rounded the corner in the hallway to stop in front of a private room all the way in the back.

Upon entering, it was easily identified as Aoyama's computer room.

All around on every wall were large monitors and several desktops. Various live cameras' footage was running off the side on smaller screens and on the larger ones were rows and rows of data coding and files.

Aoyama shut the door, turned to him, and said, "Why are you cashing in that favor right *now*? Did you not get the memo about Tomura being on edge?"

"I did but I really need this favor," Izuku said. "I know it's a lot to ask, especially after Nine tortured you to get all that information on me during the incident—"

"Nine didn't torture me." Aoyama corrected. "Don't feel guilty about any of that, please."

Izuku paused. Then he said, "What do you mean?"

"Um, he only asked me what happened." Aoyama shrugged a bit. "I told him everything willingly, just to be clear. I care for you Izuku, but I am not willing to bleed for you. That's not a trait we share."

A beat of silence passed.

"I understand," Izuku said awkwardly. Aoyama was a viper at the end of the day. "That's my own…defect."

The word 'defect' didn't feel the same anymore.

“It is,” Aoyama said. “Now, what was the favor?”

Izuku shrugged the bad feeling off and whispered, “I need you to tamper with my tracker.”

“Wh-What?” Aoyama stammered. Beads of sweat gathered on his hairline. “What tracker? What are you talking about—”

“—Drop the act,” Izuku quipped in a flat tone. He dug his gaze directly into Aoyama, not backing down. “I know we have them. And since you’re the head of technology it makes sense that you have access to the data. Now, show me.”

Izuku made the conclusion about the trackers after The Incident.

When the numbness in his leg disappeared the second, he walked back into The Academy, Izuku knew what it was.

He had no clue when it was placed in his leg or exactly *where,* but it all made sense. The first clue was that Hiryu had been found quickly on his first escape. But not so quickly on his second after he clawed everywhere on his back to *scrape* something out. All that coupled with how Tomura so easily found him after he crawled through the sewage only pointed to one, devious thing.

Aoyama stared at him with feigned innocence for exactly ten more seconds. Then his expression shifted to being unamused.

“You really are too smart for your own good sometimes, Izuku,” Aoyama said with a sigh.

He sat down in a large blue chair. With three clicks of his mouse, the giant computer screen in front of Izuku changed. It lit up to a dark mode world map with hundreds of green dots and six yellow ones.

Izuku knew he was one of the yellow ones when he saw how many were clustered in Tokyo. Five.

But there was one yellow dot not in Japan.

Izuku took the mouse and hovered over that dot. The dot expanded to show a large headshot of Himiko.

“What is Himiko doing in Bangkok?” Izuku asked.

“She’s on a five-month mission,” Aoyama explained. “She started last week on a deep undercover assignment to dismantle a growing assassin school there. They ripped off The Viper Academy model and One wants them to be cut down at the legs so we don’t have any competition.”

Izuku strummed his fingers along the counter. He probed his tongue into his cheek as he thought about his next big move and how risky this might all be.

But Katsuki was worth every single risk.

“Switch our signals and make it look like I took the mission instead of her,” Izuku said. “And tell One I’m out on the assignment before you tell Tomura.”

Aoyama furrowed his brow, utterly shocked. “Why, Izuku?”

“…My ankle is really badly hurt,” Izuku said. He pleaded deeply with his eyes. “I shattered it in several places, and I want time to recover without Tomura around. You know how he gets when I come back with a stupid type of injury. I don’t really want to go through that right now, so I booked an AirBnB in isolation.”

Aoyama’s expression easily softened.

He glanced down at Izuku’s ankle cast and his bandaged wrist. He carefully assessed the damage.

“He would beat you blue for that type of injury,” Aoyama muttered a bit sourly. He began typing and gave Izuku a sympathetic glance. “I’ll try my best to cover for you. Where are you going?”

“I’ll be in a little town in the countryside,” Izuku said. “It’s private and isolated. It’ll be inconspicuous.”

“Perfect,” Aoyama said as he typed. “Thankfully Tomura couldn’t care less what Himiko does as long as she’s not in his sights. I’ll tell him she’s putting in PTO time for a while. Do you want me to watch Katsuma while you’re out?”

“Yes, please. After this I owe you big, okay?”

“Yes you do. Be safe. Don’t let him see you on the way out.”

Izuku watched as his and Himiko’s head shots both popped up on the map above their dots. With ease, their pictures swapped, and it now looked as if Izuku was in Thailand and Himiko was in Tokyo.

ɯɯɯ

Departure for Honeymoon

Izuku walked out of The Viper Academy with his bag and his hopes. He bought himself more time with Katsuki, but his original mission was not forgotten in his mind. He looked up at the tall skyscraper pensively. He tore his eyes away slowly when he sensed a peculiar pull shift in the atmosphere.

They walked out of Hadeus discreetly, and Izuku’s heart hammered with every step they took together down this new road.

“So where are we going exactly?” Izuku asked.

Katsuki’s smile grew slightly sad. “My mother’s home.”

Izuku reached out and held his hand tightly. “I’m sure it’s lovely.”

Chapter End Notes

Lemme know what you think below!!

It's been nice to fill in the gaps from Katsuki's POV in Izuku's :)) I'm super excited to kick off this fluffier arc :3 Scenes from the Honeymoon that weren't in Katsuki's will be in Izuku's to give more fun times and love between them. It's crazy to think we're going to be coming around the corner soon to lap Katsuki's POV and then nose dive into the pits of hell :))

Thank you so much for reading!!

Chapter 24: Amoroso

Chapter Summary

Amoroso (Stylistic expression) to play loving

Chapter Notes

Helloooo!! Welcome back to this choo choo train! First, thank you to the LOML Luna for Betaing! This stop and the next are well earned fluff after all the angst, I really love writing these two and having them fall in love all over again from Izuku's POV has been awesome :') can't wait for you all to read!

Warnings: Adult scenes and themes

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 24 — Amoroso

.

.

.

Izuku couldn’t tear his eyes away from Katsuki while on the train ride to Biei.

They were seated side by side and with every train stop, it became clearer just how insane this all was. He was practically running away with Kacchan for four months, lying to Tomura, and on top of that he was *married*. Izuku glanced down at their intertwined hands. Both of their fake rings glimmered under the small light above them.

Katsuki had his head leaned back on the head rest and half of his face was covered by a small, black face mask. His eyes were closed in a blissful nap. Izuku tried to relax as well, but he was too anxious. He needed to keep his ears peeled for the angry phone call he knew was coming.

Then as if Tomura could read his mind, the tell-tale ringtone sang into the air.

He pulled out his phone to see the number ‘117’ staring at him like a terrible omen. He knew this was coming and he practiced what he was going to say over and over in his head. With gentle care, Izuku slowly peeled himself away from Katsuki, trying his best not to wake him.

But the second he let go of Katsuki's hand, the man's eyes fluttered open.

Intense scarlet eyes homed in on him and Katsuki was visibly confused. Izuku's heart pulled, and he quickly told Katsuki he needed to go to the bathroom and he'd be right back. Katsuki tiredly grunted and went back to napping.

Izuku took his leave to slowly hobble down the narrow aisle of the train. He found the bathroom and locked himself in the small space. He leaned against the tiny wall and answered the phone.

"Izuku!" Tomura's voice boomed with wrath before Izuku could even greet him. He winced and held the phone away from his ear. "Why the *hell* are you in Bangkok right now on a five month assignment?!"

Izuku steadied his nerves as he recited the lie he practiced.

"One sent me here the moment I came back," Izuku said quietly. "We had a small verbal exchange before he left our headquarters. He was impressed by the Moore mission enough that he asked me to embark on this undercover assignment for him. I-I didn't feel like it was my place to question him or say no. Unless, you want to. I'm sure he'd be more receptive to you questioning him."

That final sentence was a ballsy bluff.

Like expected, the silence that followed was loud. Izuku knew Tomura was squeezing the life out of his stress ball right now because Tomura was brave but not brave enough to question a decision One potentially made.

"If that's what One wants, then *fine*," Tomura said through his gritted teeth. "You really should have told me about this before going. I do not like being left out of the loop on assignments, even if it is One. I'll allow it since it's already in the system. But I want you to know that I will be adding an extra week to the time you're going to be spending with Chisaki because of this."

Izuku swallowed.

It was beginning to shape up like every time he chose Katsuki, he dug his grave deeper into the pits of hell.

"Of course," Izuku agreed while tightening his grip on the phone. "I was going to suggest you do that as well to smooth it over."

He wasn't, but he needed Tomura to believe he wasn't avoiding this whole ordeal.

"Chisaki gave me his schedule for the next six months," Tomura said curtly. "Luckily, it seems like he has two weeks available five months from now. I'll get it blocked off with him immediately."

Tomura told him the exact date and Izuku tried not to let himself hyper fixate on it. But he felt the numbers carve themselves into his collar bone directly next to his mark and sealed his

fate. Tomura said his goodbyes and Izuku did as well.

When he hung up, he stared distantly at the dirty sink in front of him.

Five months was a long way away. That was enough time to find the homes of the last cohort and work on a strategy to get them out. And it was also enough time to get to know Katsuki better before he was handed over to Chisaki like some object.

A lick of spitefulness nicked the back of his throat.

He was glad his real first time was with Katsuki.



First Month of Honeymoon

When they arrived at the estate it was a remarkable sight.

Standing in front of them like two guardians were large, metal gates riddled with rust. Beyond them laid a spacious garden of wilted, dead flowers and a pond in the center. Grisly moss overtook the surface of the water, and there were no signs of life anywhere.

But all Izuku saw were the past lives this place had housed.

He re-painted the scene in his mind to be full of ebullience.

The vision of whoever the Bakugou family was danced across his imagination. Laughter was probably like music as it bounced off the rickety walls and the savory smell of home cooked food would waft into the air as a warm welcome. It was easy to envision the calm, slow life land like this afforded a family and it made Izuku content knowing Katsuki was retiring here. Out of everyone Izuku knew, Katsuki deserved a stable life the most.

“It’s beautiful,” Izuku said honestly.

Katsuki didn’t say much, and Izuku wondered why. He then wondered why such a large estate was empty now, and seemed deeply neglected. Someone clearly had loved this land enough to invest in it, but somewhere down the line it all fell apart.

Katsuki sighed tiredly and led them through the front door.

Once inside, the smell of dust and cobwebs tickled at his nose. To normal people this would likely make them believe this place was a useless dump, but to Izuku it felt like the nook. He lived a lavish life most of the time, but with all the glitter came the price of pain. The only true tranquility he knew was that old, forgotten room that was covered in cobwebs.

They began to get settled in the home and it was then Izuku noticed sun-bleached spots on the walls. They were in the shape of small picture frames, but no photos were in sight. The presence of ghosts pushed against his skin when he ran his fingers across the worn surface.

He asked Katsuki if he grew up here and was surprised to learn he hadn't. Then furthermore, he was even sadder to know Katsuki was never given the chance to know his blood family outside of his mother.

That part made Izuku pause and take a good look at Katsuki.

It was then he realized there was a lot about Katsuki's life he didn't know.

"It's fine, let's not mention it. Alright?" Katsuki muttered after explaining. "It's only me living here now and that's probably all it's ever going to be."

Izuku took the hint to back off but that thought made him somber.

They continued to walk around the house and Katsuki showed him every room—except one. The room they didn't tour was closed off and the door was painted a whole different color. Red. Similar to Katsuki's eyes. Seeing his favorite shade of red made him excited a bit. He asked what was behind the door like it wasn't a big deal, but apparently to Katsuki it was.

"Don't ever step foot in there," Katsuki warned. "I mean it. I need to take that room apart and I would prefer to do it privately when I'm ready."

"…Okay. Sorry for asking," Izuku muttered. He eyed the closed door suspiciously. "I'm sorry. I didn't mean to pry."

"No need to be sorry," Katsuki said. He hooked his arm around Izuku's shoulders and led him away. "But leave that door shut. C'mon, let's fix up your room and handicap the house for you until the bedding is finished."

Izuku nodded in understanding, but as they rounded the corner he stole one last glance behind him at the red door covered in cobwebs.

ᔓᔓᔓ

After the miniature tour and washing clean sheets, they danced around each other slightly. Both their eyes were skirting downwards and Izuku rubbed his upper arm nervously. He saw Katsuki shift on his feet, as if wanting to say something as their unresolved feelings loomed between them.

However, one glance at Katsuki's beautiful eyes and Izuku decided to continue being brave.

He worked himself up to ask Katsuki to sleep in the same bed, and much to his relief, Katsuki eagerly agreed. The spark inside of Katsuki's eyes from his request was like a fireworks show, and soon they took their place side by side in the primary bedroom.

It should have worried Izuku how *right* it felt for them to lay side by side. Never in his life had he laid in a bed without the threat of Tomura around the corner or down the hall. But here with Katsuki, he found himself shrouded by peace and warmth.

The hammering in his chest was a brand new experience. His pulse was racing faster than any bullet he shot so Izuku followed the pull in his heart and slotted himself against Katsuki's side. Katsuki eagerly accepted him and wrapped his arms around him to pull him closer.

Izuku continued his bold streak and intertwined their fingers together.

They both stared at their rings in utter silence. It hurt Izuku like a pulsing cavity in his mouth to think about removing the ring. So he ignored it like many would with a cavity. He'd address it later when it was absolutely necessary to do so.

"Can we cross that bridge when we get there?" Izuku whispered before Katsuki could mention anything about separating. "We'll discuss…the marriage but not right now. I have something else on my mind."

Katsuki nodded. "That's fine. We can talk about it tomorrow."

Izuku cusped Katsuki's hand tighter. He thought about the daunting realization he came to after their headquarters mission. He felt strangely inclined to let Katsuki know.

Because that's what you did when you loved someone, right?

"…I," Izuku started but stopped.

He tried to press himself to say the words *'I love you'* but found them glued to the back of his tongue. He glanced into Katsuki's eyes for a moment and his shyness came back full force. Suddenly all he could think about were the negative views Katsuki had on romance.

"…I like you, Katsuki," Izuku whispered delicately, downgrading his feelings a notch.

Izuku's anxiety rose to new heights as he laid himself bare. He looked at Katsuki whose eyes were now wide in shock.

"Do—Do you like me too?" Izuku asked cautiously when he was met with silence. "I-It's okay if you don't. I get it. You said you don't do all that type of stuff—"

"—I like you too," Katsuki blurted out.

Izuku's eyes widened too.

They both stared at each other in slight disbelief. Izuku nervously smiled as his heart rate sped up and he could feel Katsuki's heart do the same.

"Th-That makes me happy to hear," Izuku said with a bashful chuckle. "I thought for a second you were, uh, going to say you liked me but not like *that*."

"You think it'd ask you to come live with me for a couple of months if I didn't like you in that way?" Katsuki smirked. "Yeah, I wanted to make sure you're taken care of and healed, but I'll admit there's…other motives. Selfish ones." He gripped Izuku's hand tightly. "Is that bad?"

“No. I was selfish for coming here too.” Izuku’s eyes darted off to the side. “I-I wanted more time with you and this feels—*good*. I’m not decent at talking about myself or my feelings, but I feel like I’m supposed to be here with you.”

“You—” Katsuki licked his lips. “I feel like you’re supposed to be here too.”

Izuku couldn’t help but wonder what would have happened if they did run off together. Without the complications of reality between them, what would they be like? These next four months were their chance to know what could have been. It was a painful sentiment, but sweet nonetheless.

Katsuki began tenderly stroking his skin with his thumb.

“You know, I had a crush on you when we were kids,” Izuku confessed.

Katsuki let out a sharp laugh. “Hah. I figured.”

“What gave it away?” Izuku laughed too.

“Possibly the dumb fake marriage and giving each other kisses every day.”

“To be fair, the fake marriage was *your* idea.” Izuku grinned at the memory of young Katsuki teaching him about love. He leaned in and rested his chin against Katsuki’s chest and gazed at him adoringly. “Does this mean you had a crush on me too?”

“I didn’t realize it, but yeah, I liked you a lot,” Katsuki whispered. He traced a finger up and down Izuku’s spine and Izuku turned into putty knowing his feelings were possibly returned by a fraction. “I couldn’t stop thinking about you even if I tried. Then *unfortunately* I think I was crushing on you as *Deku* too over the years.”

Izuku’s eyes lit up. He quickly felt silly for ever thinking Katsuki hated him. They *both* liked each other, all these years.

“I was, uh, crushing on you too—over the years,” Izuku shyly confessed. “I looked forward to seeing the cranky guy with bad aim sometimes.”

Katsuki scoffed. “Bad aim? I have excellent fucking aim.”

“Sure you do.” Izuku chuckled. “But, I would secretly hope to run into you, even though it would mean I missed my mark.”

Katsuki raised a brow. “Really?”

“I thought it was obvious. I let you go every single time.”

Katsuki looked at him as if he never noticed.

And with that, their entire eight years of push and pull boiled down to something neither of them thought: mutual fondness.

But Izuku didn't dare confess about how much he loved Katsuki. He was still too scared that a confession of that weight would make Katsuki take flight and never return. His reaction to knowing Izuku loved him would be iffy because Katsuki was clearly adjusting to his new feelings the same way Izuku was. And besides, they had months to relax with each other. Izuku didn't want to ruin it.

The night continued on with them talking about various subjects, and Izuku was amazed how easily Katsuki was warming up without his emotional wall.

They discussed some of their encounters in a new light. Izuku smiled when Katsuki confessed to nearly asking him out on a date in Taiwan *and* in Vienna. And Izuku confessed right back how his heart stopped at the sight of Katsuki in Vienna.

Izuku anxiously brushed Katsuki's hair behind his ear when Katsuki's eyes fluttered closed. He watched as the man he loved drifted off to sleep in the middle of a story while their hands were still intertwined.

As he laid there watching Katsuki gently snore, it felt too good to be true.

Izuku half expected Tomura to barge through the door come morning. He lowered his head above Katsuki's heart and allowed the metronome to carry him off peacefully to his dreams in case the worst happened in the morning.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When the next day came, Izuku was relieved to find no texts or calls from Tomura. He got confirmation from Aoyama that they were in the clear and he would give Izuku a heads up if anything urgent came to light. Other than that, Izuku could relax and let his ankle heal.

Izuku could barely believe it.

He stared at the canopy above the bed in shock. Somehow, his plan worked and Tomura was not kicking in the door. He glanced to his side to see Katsuki. The other man had his arms securely wrapped around Izuku's middle as he buried his face in Izuku's head of curls. He was peacefully sound asleep.

Warmth spread all over.

Izuku sat up and was careful not to wake Katsuki.

With gentle care, Izuku leaned over the side of the bed and pulled his backpack close to him. He reached down inside and grabbed his laptop, plopping it on his lap. He opened it and put the screen brightness down to the lowest setting as he began to type.

He decided this was the night to get to work in case the moment slipped past him. He already was derailed enough during Paradise. While he loved Katsuki, he couldn't forget the whole reason he took that assignment.

Izuku began to look up missing children reports in Japan and started his search.

It took a tedious amount of time. Finding the specific families for the five kids was harder than he thought, and his body rocked with nausea at just how *many* missing people reports there were. Dozens, if not hundreds, popped up daily.

He was able to narrow it down to reports of infants missing from hospitals five years ago. There he found about fifty open cases. They were from a number of various, scattered places. He meticulously went one by one to compare facial features of every child to the parents. Slowly, he uncovered the reports and was able to find four families and their new addresses.

Eri's family was still looking for her.

Kota's assumed he died.

Hana's was still searching but not actively, and the family had fallen apart.

Tamashiro's parents had gotten a divorce and were living separately.

And lastly, Katsuma's family was nowhere to be found.

Izuku clicked on article after article but it seemed like a strange dead end was prohibiting him. It appeared like Katsuma's family searched *heavily* for him the first year he went missing, and suddenly they vanished from the face of the earth without a trace. Izuku scoured social media for the mother or father but found nothing.

Worry gnawed at Izuku's gut, but he reassured himself it would be okay.

Katsuma's family was likely very private. He could try to get to Aoyama's advanced system back home and track them that way.

Izuku wrote down the information for the other kids in his tiny notebook. Once he finished, he powered down his laptop and tucked it back in his backpack. He turned to look at Katsuki next to him who slept the whole time. He snuggled back in and allowed himself to fall asleep peacefully for the first time in years.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When they decided to get up, it was as if Izuku's body shifted out of viper mode for the first time in his twenty five years of life. He had no clue the human body could feel so pliant and sluggish.

They walked around the house and Katsuki immediately needed to take a phone call from his supervisor. Izuku took the moment to relax by the window in the kitchen and appreciate the summer day. The warm breeze swept through his hair as he leaned against the windowsill and the smell of fresh greenery filled his lungs.

When Katsuki finally got back over to him, they engaged in a small conversation. Katsuki let it spill that he was officially in retirement, but something was off.

Izuku was an expert of body language. He could see the slight slouch in Katsuki's shoulders and how his arms were closed across his body. Katsuki wasn't comfortable with the new adjustment in his life. When Izuku asked why, Katsuki revealed he wasn't used to relaxing.

That part pained Izuku.

He was curious what exactly happened in Katsuki's life that led him down the route of being a hitman. Based on the far off look in Katsuki's eyes right now, the story was nothing good.

"Let's get you used to resting," Izuku promised above a whisper. He intertwined their hands because that was all he could think of to help ease the anxiety. It worked like a charm. "You deserve to rest. What's the first thing you want to do in your retirement?"

"Probably grocery shop so we don't starve," Katsuki said. "Can't relax if we've got empty stomachs."

Izuku laughed lightly and leaned in all the way. He gripped Katsuki's hand harder as he grinned.

"Good point! Let's do that first then. Kacc—Katsuki."

Izuku's heart skipped a beat.

They stared at each other for a moment before they both broke out in matching blushes. Izuku's face deepened to a dark red and his grip on Katsuki loosened a bit. He was about to apologize, but Katsuki quickly gripped his hand tighter and leaned in.

"You can call me Kacchan if you want," Katsuki said gently in his lowest voice.

Izuku thought for sure he would melt right there. Katsuki got so close to his face that Izuku could see all the different kinds of reds swirling in his eyes along with passion.

"Really?" Izuku asked softly. "You said you hated pet names a while ago."

"Well." Katsuki cleared his throat. "Kacchan is fine. It's different."

"Okay." Izuku smiled. "Kacchan it is."

Katsuki then glanced down at their wedding rings, and Izuku followed his gaze.

There was silence so strong Izuku found himself in a chokehold from it. They could take these off now since they didn't have to fool anyone that they were married. But neither of them spoke a word as they studied the cheap, fake rings.

Katsuki began caressing Izuku's skin with his thumb. It was here Izuku decided that they didn't need to jump any hurdles, and they could take the moment to relax and appreciate each other.

The next two weeks consisted of Izuku watching Katsuki clean up the estate and make it into a home.

If his ankle wasn't fractured in several places, Izuku would have gladly helped. But he was more or less forced to sit and observe due to Katsuki not wanting him to hurt himself further.

He wasn't complaining though. He shamelessly ogled Katsuki as he plucked weeds from the garden with his shirt off. The sweltering summer sun beat down on them and sweat glistened along Katsuki's chest and back muscles.

Izuku bit his lip every time Katsuki took a pause to wipe his brow.

Katsuki would always glance over at him and give a playful wink if he caught Izuku staring. Izuku would then blush, bury his nose in his book and shyly peek over it to continue to watch.

At night during this peaceful interlude, they found themselves cuddled up on the couch with a fuzzy blanket. It was big enough to envelope both of them as they watched old, romance films. At first Izuku was shocked by this development. It was like entering an alternate dimension when Katsuki was the one to suggest they put one on.

"Which one of your sappy movies is the best gateway?" Katsuki randomly asked one night.

Izuku was stunned to near silence but still managed to say, "Uh, I think you might enjoy *In The Mood For Love*."

Katsuki nodded like he was a picky eater about to try a new food.

While watching the movie, Izuku noticed how Katsuki sat up right, more attentive at a specific scene. Su Li-zhen Chan and Chow Mo-wan were caught in the rain under a small awning, waiting for the storm to ease up. They were not facing each other as the pitter patter of rain droplets echoed through the night.

"I didn't think you'd fall in love with me," Su Li-zhen said quietly. Her eyes were pointed down to the puddle that was at her feet.

Chow Mo-Wan didn't speak right away. He smiled sadly to himself as he said, "I didn't either. I was only curious to know how it started. Now I know. Feelings can creep up just like that." He then turned to face her and held her hand. "I thought I was in control."

Katsuki pursed his lips, eyes tethered to the screen.

He then slowly grabbed Izuku's hand. He didn't let it go for the rest of the film.

After they finished that movie, it was an avalanche of romantic comedies, epic romances, and more. However, Izuku couldn't stop himself from watching Katsuki more than the screen.

The anti-romantic man seemed far more interested in the films than he should be, as if he was curiously studying the affection between the two protagonists.

Then on a particular night while they were in the middle of streaming *The Notebook* in the living room, Izuku found himself lying flat on top of Katsuki with his head against his chest. To their side was a bowl of freshly microwaved popcorn and an assortment of half eaten candy bars. Katsuki's eyes were glued to the television and Izuku's eyes were glued to Katsuki.

Katsuki's physique was something Izuku couldn't quite get enough of. It still blew his mind that this was the scrawny boy from the nook.

While the movie was still playing, Izuku discreetly took his hand and tried to wrap it around Katsuki's bicep. He then attempted to see how many of his own fists made up Katsuki's forearm and it was ridiculous. What did this man *eat* every day?

"I think you have a size kink, nerd," Katsuki randomly interjected. "Is that why you watch all this fan-service stuff? You thirst over all the unrealistically muscular guys?"

Izuku spooked a bit, caught red handed. He smiled sheepishly down at Katsuki who was grinning from ear to ear.

"I don't," Izuku said honestly. "I think it's only you that I like being this, er, *big*."

Katsuki let out a small 'pfft' as if he didn't believe Izuku. "Yeah right. There's no way you're watching all these dorky movies and not eye fucking the guys."

"It's true!" Izuku retorted quickly. "I-I'm not!"

"Ya-huh. *Sure*. You probably have a life sized poster of Fabio stashed in your room somewhere that you jack off to."

"Really," Izuku insisted. He began drawing circles on Katsuki's arm while blushing. "This might, um, sound strange, but it just makes me *really* happy to see you well fed and large? Especially after everything you went through, y'know. It gives me some sort of comfort knowing you grew up to be strong after you were so frail. I-I guess, what I am trying to say is, it makes me happy to know you're healthy after thinking the worst happened to you for most of my life."

Katsuki's smirk faltered.

His expression became incredibly serious and Izuku felt embarrassed for his ramble. He averted his eyes and let go of Katsuki's arm.

"Now that I say that out loud it's embarrassing," Izuku mumbled as he twiddled his fingers.

"…I never thought about it like that," Katsuki said quietly. "That's understandable."

"Really?" Izuku asked.

"Yeah." Katsuki lifted Izuku's hand and placed it back where it was on his arm. "Plus, it makes me a little glad to know I'm the only guy you might have a thing for. I tend to have a, ah, *bad* jealousy streak so this is going to my head a bit."

Katsuki smiled at him with a tiny blush along his cheeks.

Izuku blushed right back and kneaded Katsuki's skin. They continued to watch the movie and this time around, he took his time running his hands along Katsuki in slow, deliberate motions.

He appreciated everything about Katsuki as they watched the movie in silence.

The character Allie Hamilton was on screen, tears pouring down her beautiful face as she sat in her car. She clutched a letter from Noah in her hands as she read it. The gentle voice of her lover was in the background reciting Izuku's favorite quote from the movie.

"The best love is the kind that awakens the soul and makes us reach for more, that plants a fire in our hearts and brings peace to our minds. And that's what you've given me. That's what I'd hoped to give to you forever."

Izuku stole a glance at Katsuki as he soaked in the words with a new understanding.

ᔓᔓᔓ

The next week the estate was officially breathed back to life. There were no more cobwebs, only the smell of mint, cinnamon and various savory foods lingering in the halls.

Him and Katsuki grew into a routine during this time, and it was lovely. Izuku could feel his ankle get slightly better, but he was more focused on how relaxed Katsuki was. He finally was warming up to the life he deserved.

One day while laying under a tree staring up at the clouds, Izuku learned something new about Katsuki.

"I…I always wanted to make classical music," Katsuki confessed while looking up at one cloud that was in the shape of a violin.

Izuku shifted in the grass to stare at him curiously. Katsuki kept his eyes trained upwards, looking like the sky held many of his unanswered questions in life.

Katsuki continued to stare up as he said, "It's always something I kept pushing to the side all my life for more important things. But I've always had an interest in composing."

"Is it because of that old violinist we knew?" Izuku asked curiously.

Katsuki nodded. "I'm going to take a wild guess that's why you like to play violin as well."

"We're two nerds cut from the same cloth I think." Izuku laughed, feeling connected to Katsuki on a deeper level now. "Have you looked into classical music lessons? That could be a good step into your new life."

Katsuki shrugged. "Ah, no. I suppose I could. I never thought about it."

Izuku could see it now: Katsuki in his own private study finally living out his dreams as a composer. On the walls would be posters of famous composers. And at his desk would be hundreds of perfectly organized music sheets with notes that when strung together made the perfect melody.

Izuku smiled at the thought.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Later that night, Izuku eagerly looked up Music Composition classes on his phone.

They were currently all settled in bed under the covers watching Casablanca on the new TV Katsuki mounted across the wall. The old black and white movie drew all of Katsuki's attention while he subconsciously drew hearts along Izuku's thigh.

"Kiss me," the actress on screen said breathily. "Kiss me as if it was the last time."

Katsuki squeezed Izuku's thigh as he watched the two lover's kiss in a desperate embrace. Izuku smiled at the action and clicked on link after link until he found one that was suitable. His eyes lit up at the fact these classes were within walking distance and affordable.

"Look," Izuku exclaimed happily. "Here's some classical music composition classes for you."

Katsuki turned to him. He slowly took the phone and read it. He looked at Izuku slightly surprised but clear excitement was gleaming in his eyes.

"This can be your second life, Kacchan," Izuku encouraged. "You should sign up tonight and we can go to the classes that start next month together. I'll just sit in the corner but I would love to see you do this. I can picture you as a composer already. You'd be so awesome at it."

"You really think so?" Katsuki asked quietly.

Izuku nodded in confidence. "I would bet my life on it. You'd be amazing at anything you put your mind to, Kacchan. You already have a great ear for classical music, I bet you're an amazing musical composer waiting to happen."

It took Katsuki less than a minute to pull out his laptop and apply to the class.

As Katsuki applied, Izuku heard the background of the movie whisper the lines, "That day you left Paris, if you knew how much I went through. If you knew how much I loved you. How much I *still* love you."

Izuku's heart clutched when he realized he related a bit too much to that. All that was needed was a small change from Paris to Tokyo. He ignored the pounding in his chest as he rubbed Katsuki's back lovingly and put his chin on his shoulder.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Shortly after Katsuki signed up for the music composition class, he suddenly was very eager to hear Izuku play violin.

“You should play for me,” Katsuki said a little too sweetly while they were out in the garden. He held a bundle of pink carnations that he plucked in his hands. He slowly leaned in and gave them to Izuku. “You did say you always wanted to play for an audience. I wanna hear you play.”

Izuku thought it would be an easy ‘of course I will!’ but found himself faced with complicated emotions. It wasn’t because he was nervous, he played for their clients many times, but this was different. He wanted to play for Katsuki all his life. But it was nearly dreamlike to have what was always a far off wish be directly in his grasp.

“O-Okay,” Izuku whispered while taking the pink carnations. “I’ll play for you.”

He could barely say no to Katsuki even if he wanted to.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Later that night Izuku was full of nerves.

The sky decided to give them a steady downpour of rain. When it was like this, Katsuki enjoyed shutting off the lights and strictly using candles and the fireplace. Izuku took a seat in the wooden rocking chair by the fire while Katsuki splayed across the floor on the red rug.

Izuku looked between Katsuki and the damaged, white violin in his hands.

He stared at Katsuki for a long time, still unsure if this was all real. He studied the way the yellowish lighting hit Katsuki’s eyes and painted across his skin. His beautiful hair was softened in the light, drawing Izuku’s attention to his high cheekbones. The intense look pouring out from Katsuki’s alluring eyes was profound.

“This feels…” Izuku trailed off, unsure what the right words were.

“…Like a long time coming?” Katsuki supplied.

Izuku nodded sadly. He sucked in his breath and decided to take the first step.

He began to play the one song he always wanted to play for Katsuki. The Dance of The Love Birds.

He played it like he wished he did when he was eight. He imagined himself in the plaza by himself messing up the notes until his fingertips burned. They stung from the bitter cold, then slowly they began to ache from the summer sun. He practiced all that year until he got it right because this was the melody that brought them together. If he perfected it, Kacchan would hear it and come running back to him.

Just like before.

As Izuku strung his bow, a full year of bitter abandonment flowed through the low notes. And then when the notes went high, he channeled the hopeful feeling he always held inside of him that maybe one day he could see Kacchan again. And when he came to the end of the song, Izuku opened his eyes to see Katsuki there, staring at him like he was the most beautiful thing in the world.

A tear escaped and slid down Izuku's face, but quickly he wiped it away.

"S-Sorry," Izuku whispered as he hurried to hide his emotions. "I don't know what that was."

Katsuki slowly rose from the rug. He walked over to where Izuku was sitting and cradled his face in his hands. Without warning, Izuku's tears flowed down more and his chest convulsed slightly.

"I always wanted to play for you," Izuku whispered. "I used to dream of it all the time when I was younger. It's…It's why I started playing violin. I used to think if I played in the plaza, you would come back to me one day if you recognized the song. Even if you didn't recognize me."

They both searched each other's eyes for a long time until Izuku reached out for Katsuki. Just to make sure he was real and so was this moment. He ran his hand along Katsuki's captivating face. Then slowly, Katsuki stroked Izuku's tears away with his thumb. Katsuki leaned in like he always did and Izuku's heart clenched.

"You played beautifully, darling," Katsuki whispered.

Darling.

Katsuki said it naturally and seriously. Not a lick of sarcasm. No snideness. Not even a flirtatious incline that was meant to rile him up. He said 'darling' purely out of adoration for Izuku.

Izuku's heart swooned so deeply he knew he would never recover.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When they went to sleep that night, the atmosphere was heavy against Izuku's soul.

Never in his life had someone called him such a sweet name with pure intentions. A small voice in the back of his head told him that Katsuki cared for him more than anyone. The quiet thought felt taboo because he always believed the person who cared for him most was Tomura.

"I'm the only person who would ever truly give a damn about you," was Tomura's constant mantra.

"No one cares for you as much as me," Tomura would always say.

"I know you best," Tomura regularly reminded him.

Izuku clung to Katsuki tighter as he struggled to grasp what the true meaning of ‘caring for another person’ meant. He thought he knew. But now he wasn’t so sure.

He thought it was care when Tomura stopped him from going to the basement. He thought Tomura held his best intentions in mind when he opened his eyes to the truth about Inko. He even assumed it was brotherly love when Tomura helped him pass The Cull.

It made sense. While cruel, his brother always looked out for him and he never left Izuku to the wolves.

Katsuki fell asleep first and Izuku gave himself a headache from thinking too much. He decided then to take a small stroll around the estate to give himself some peace of mind. Maybe hobbling would wear him down. Izuku carefully got out of bed and grabbed his crutches. He slowly limped out of the bedroom and took a small lap around.

At night the estate was calming. All the old hallways felt like a safety blanket wrapped around his arms. As he passed each room, he smiled thinking about all the memories they made already.

But he paused when he passed by one particular room.

He turned to face the red door Katsuki refused to touch. Izuku pensively studied the large spider’s web stretched across it that caught the moonlight. He peered over his shoulder down the dark hallway and decided one peak couldn’t hurt.

He wobbled forward and twisted the doorknob.

Nothing could have prepared him for what was inside.

The room was small, full of toys, and there was a window that was veiled with old white curtains. Sitting in the ledge was a forgotten vase of wilted carnations with evidence of decay crawling all over it. Off to the side was an old rug meant for a baby to crawl on and a broken crib.

But worst of all, above the fractured crib was the name ‘Katsuki’ in chipped, scarlet lettering.

Izuku’s heart dropped.

He tried to flick on the light but was met with utter darkness. His curiosity scratched at him despite knowing this was against Katsuki’s wishes. He carefully wobbled back down the hall to where he knew the spare light bulbs were and grabbed one.

He made his way back to the room and walked. Immediately something crunched underneath his crutches. He looked down, but in the darkness he couldn’t make out what he was stepping on.

Izuku found an old lamp, changed the bulb, and plugged it in.

The tiny blue lamp poured light everywhere. All around were old blankets, dust, and forgotten gadgets that were meant for a newborn. This was *Katsuki's* nursery. Izuku's heart clenched as he glanced down and saw pieces of old plaster shattered along the floor. He then squinted a bit when he could make out something. He leaned over a chunk that held an impression of a tiny toe.

And then his heart outright shattered when he realized the broken pieces on the floor were a plaster of baby feet.

Izuku lowered himself to the ground. He looked carefully at each smashed piece and found himself being able to connect a couple.

Suddenly, the door slammed open.

Izuku snapped his head up and found Katsuki's rage filled eyes glaring down at him. Pure fury roared in his face and Izuku felt a bone chilling ache stab into him.

"Ka-Katsuki," Izuku gasped. He put his hands up when he could see the anger in Katsuki rising like thick smog. "Wait—"

"—What the fuck, Izuku?" Katsuki seethed. "What the actual *fuck*?! I said not to come in here!"

Izuku held one of his hands up while the other curled around pieces of the shattered plaster. "I-I know but I wanted to see—"

"—*No*!" Katsuki cut off unkindly, raising his voice. "If I say not to come in here, don't fucking do it! This is *my* house. I don't even want to be in here right now—"

Katsuki's eyes looked around for less than a second, and they stopped at the crib.

Izuku sat on the floor stunned when Katsuki suddenly choked on his words and stopped talking. Then like he was experiencing a real life nightmare, his expression quickly bounced between anger and anxiety. Katsuki tried to speak but tripped up—something Izuku *never* saw him do—and it looked as if he swayed slightly on his feet.

Quickly, Izuku felt staggering concern. What was happening?

The longer he watched Katsuki the more everything felt wrong. Katsuki's eyes began darting around the room then his chest convulsed. Then Katsuki clutched at his shirt.

Oh.

Oh no.

Izuku recognized what was happening: Katsuki was spiraling into a panic attack. Izuku used to have them when he was a kid, especially that year alone waiting for Katsuki. The old violinist calmed him out of several of these on his worst days.

Now directly in front of him, Katsuki's own breathing was becoming unsteady in the same way.

Quickly, Izuku tried to stand up with the help of the dresser when he realized his mistake. He triggered Katsuki.

Izuku held the broken pieces of plaster close to his chest as he called out Katsuki's name over and over. But no words could reach Katsuki. His barrier of panic was building fast, and clouding his senses. Izuku wearily watched the man he loved in pain and did the last thing he could think to calm him down. He hobbled forward and tried to soothe him.

"Kacchan. I'm sorry—" Izuku lightly touched Katsuki's shoulder.

It happened in an instant.

Out of reflex, Katsuki shoved Izuku's hand away. He pushed with his natural strength, entirely not registering his surroundings or Izuku. Izuku's breath hitched as he lost grip of the shelf that was steadying him and he toppled backwards to the ground. Izuku gasped in pain as he fell on his wrist and his head hit the floor with a hard bang.

The pieces of the broken plaster rolled across the ground and Izuku screwed his eyes shut at the immediate throb he felt in his ankle.

"Shit. Shit," Katsuki whispered and he immediately snapped out of his daze. He dropped down to his knees and reached out to steady Izuku. "Iz-Izuku, I'm sorry."

"It's okay," Izuku muttered. He lifted himself up on his forearms and winced. "You didn't mean it. It was a reflex."

"No. It's not okay. I'm sorry. I'm so fucking *sorry*," Katsuki insisted. He quickly gathered Izuku up in his arms and inspected his wrist and ankle. Izuku felt guilty as ounces of regret poured from Katsuki's eyes. "I didn't mean to make you fall like that. I would never hurt you on purpose, *fuck*. I'm so goddamn sorry."

"You didn't hurt me, Kacchan. It was an accident. I fell." Izuku tried to smile to give him some reassurance that it would be okay. He sat up in Katsuki's arms and lightly touched his hand. "I shouldn't have come in here anyways. I get so curious sometimes...I can't help it but I didn't realize this room was…*yours*."

Katsuki wearily glanced around at the dust covered shelves and the scattered broken pieces on the floor. His breathing slowly evened out and Izuku felt Katsuki's hold on him tighten the longer they waded in silence.

"It…It's not mine," Katsuki said out after a stretch of silence and he hung his head. "I don't like coming in here, Izuku. I tried. So many fucking times. But I can't stand being in here."

The pain etched across Katsuki's face was too much. Izuku felt terrible. He shouldn't have come in here, he crossed a line.

"I'm really sorry," Izuku said. "I didn't mean to upset you. Let's get back to bed."

Izuku made a move to get up, but the arms locked around him kept him in place. Katsuki lifted his head and glanced around bitterly.

“It’s okay now,” Katsuki said. “I guess this helped rip the bandaid off. I have to do something with this room eventually, I can’t leave it as an open wound. I nearly had a fucking panic attack just stepping foot in here. I guess I’m more fucked up than I realize.”

“You’re not fucked up,” Izuku rejected gently.

“I am.” Katsuki scoffed. “Don’t even try to make me feel better. I’m fucked up but the worst part is I’m unnecessarily fucked up.”

Izuku pinched his brows together at that.

“What do you mean?” Izuku questioned.

“This room is proof my mother lied to me. All my goddamn life,” Katsuki explained. He looked up at his name written on the wall with such a strong disdain that Izuku was surprised. “I don’t want to be mad at her because she’s dead, so I avoid things that make me realize she screwed up being a mother.”

Izuku didn’t say anything. He let Katsuki continue to speak as he also glanced up at the lettering on the wall.

“It’s why I didn’t remember you right away,” Katsuki sourly confessed. “I chose to forget Tokyo for a long time because it made it easier to do what I needed to do. Then I avoided this estate because it makes me so goddamn angry to know I could’ve been *here* all this time, living a goddamn normal life…I used to justify that I was a monster because I *had* to be. But this—” He gestured angrily to his name on the wall. “—Rejects that.”

One word Katsuki used stood out.

“A monster?” Izuku softly questioned.

“Yes. A fucking *monster*,” Katsuki said the word dripped with bitter anguish.

Izuku never felt like someone was so wrong. But he let Katsuki keep going.

“But worst of all I feel like no one understands what I feel like,” Katsuki murmured. “I have colleagues who had *really* fucked up lives with no way around it. No path or outcome would change them from being the serial killers they are today. But there’s something so goddamn excruciating about knowing I *didn’t* have to be this fucking monster this whole time. I could have been normal…there was a way for me to be normal, but I didn’t have a fucking say in the decision.”

Hearing that last sentence, Izuku found himself faced to face with someone who was a mirror of his agony. Izuku knew the feeling of not getting a say in his own life all too well, and it broke his heart to hear Katsuki knew that feeling too.

Izuku gripped the hem of Katsuki’s shirt and leaned in. “…I get it.”

Katsuki made a confused face, and looked at him like there was no way they could be the same. “Izuku—”

“—No, really. I get where you’re coming from,” Izuku insisted. He licked his lips hesitantly, unsure if he should say what he was about to but he wanted Katsuki to know he wasn’t alone. “I went out and found my birth mother one day when I was thirteen.”

Katsuki stayed quiet as his eyes widened in shock.

“I thought that if I found her, she would take me in,” Izuku whispered. “I spent so much time building her up in my head, deluding myself that I was kidnapped and not sold,” Izuku said and his heart ached at facing this fact after a lifetime of ignoring it. “But when I found her, she was with her new family, and had a new baby. She—She made it very clear she didn’t want anything to do with me when I revealed I was her son.”

Katsuki sucked in a breath and held Izuku closer.

“It hurt more than anything I could think of,” Izuku whispered. His eyes glossed over, and tears started gathering inside of them. “She was living her new life with a new son. To this day I wonder what it would be like if I wasn’t given away. I…I keep track of them and she’s a good mom to him.”

Katsuki curled his fists tightly.

“I realized then I could’ve grown up normal too if I was born slightly different,” Izuku said bitterly. “I could’ve had that life, but it wasn’t my decision—and neither was yours. So, we’re the same,” Izuku concluded. “But be glad you made it through and now you get a shot at a normal life. Better late than never, right?”

He hoped Katsuki would understand that they were just two people cut from the same cloth.

Killers without a choice, but he wanted Katsuki to embrace his second shot at life.

Because Izuku would never have that.

“I’m sorry you had to go through all of that, Izuku,” Katsuki said in a soft rasp. He held on tighter to Izuku. “You didn’t deserve any of that. I wish I could fucking fix it for you. You’re much more than her decision.”

“And you’re more than your mother’s choices too I’m sure,” Izuku parroted right back, wishing to make Katsuki see that he’s not the ugly parts of himself. “B-But what I’m saying is we’re the same. I understand you, and out of anyone, I get it. We were both one decision away from not being…monsters. She hurt you by keeping this from you.”

Katsuki’s shoulders sagged forward, and Izuku carefully ran his hand through Katsuki’s hair.

Izuku scooted in to hug him and Katsuki slowly hugged him back. They both silently looked around the nursery. Then they tiredly leaned against the wall underneath Katsuki’s painted name.

Izuku could feel the ghosts of past decisions wander the halls. He wondered what life would have been like if Katsuki grew up here. He would've likely been happy. Well fed. Warm. But part of Izuku was sad when he realized that probably meant they never would have come across each other.

Suddenly, Katsuki hugged him and buried his head into Izuku's neck. Izuku was shocked by the vulnerable action.

"Are you okay?" Izuku asked carefully.

"No," Katsuki's voice cracked and he leaned in more. "*I'm not*."

Out poured all of Katsuki's heavy feelings. One by one they fell into Izuku's hands as Katsuki's well built defensive barrier came crumbling down. The weight of being in the nursery forced all of his secrets out of him—and Izuku was mortified.

He clung to Katsuki tightly when he was told about the multiple missed meals, and all he could see was the skinny fragile boy shivering in the cold. Next, Katsuki told him about how he never got a chance to flourish in school because he spent more time on other people's homework to help him pay for the bills. Izuku felt mournful for the loss of potential.

Then Izuku hurt so deeply it bottomed out of him when Katsuki told him that his first kill was when he was thirteen in order to protect his mother.

That was the same age as Izuku's first assignment.

Katsuki retold everything he went through from start to finish and didn't bother leaving out any details. He described how they bounced between motels. He elaborated on the cold nights. He shamefully talked about his mother's gambling addiction. Katsuki even told him how his mother and him buried a body and it was one of his most precious memories of her.

Then the biggest secret dropped: Imasuji Goto was his biological father. He murdered him because his mother revealed he used to beat her.

Katsuki all of a sudden made sense. Terrible, tragic sense.

The Scarlet Eyed Killer was simply a son who loved his mother enough to kill for her.

"I think what's most frightening is that I *like* it," Katsuki confessed with a terrified expression. "I like killing. I enjoy torturing scum because it's *cathartic* for me. I thought at first I was doing it reluctantly, but I don't think I am. Ever since my first kill, I feel like I sold my soul to this bloodthirsty monster inside of me."

Izuku didn't think it was a monster inside of Katsuki. He thought it was well earned anger.

Katsuki's whole life was void of stability, safety, and true compassion. He *wasn't* normal. He was forced to be an adult before his time and Izuku questioned if he ever had a childhood.

The hardships Katsuki faced in the world were heinous and it was no wonder he harbored so much unchecked anger. Because anger was the one emotion that always held your best

interest in mind. Anger was survival and it lets you know when you are being mistreated. Then it gives you the energy to do something about it unlike sadness.

And considering what Katsuki had to deal with, he needed an abundance of anger to survive.

Izuku understood Katsuki so clearly at that moment. He was a lot of things, but a monster was not one.

Katsuki slowly peeled himself from Izuku's hold and his cheeks were wet with a light trail of tears. He wearily glanced at Izuku, and waited for him to say something.

"Katsuki…" Izuku spoke his love's name with a broken voice. Tears started to pour from his eyes as he thought about all the struggles Katsuki endured. "I don't think you're the monster you think you are."

"Yes, I am," Katsuki said. He averted his gaze shamefully. "How can you say that after hearing what I've done? Especially to my own biological father?"

"To me it sounds like you did it all in the name of protecting her." Izuku forced Katsuki to look into his eyes. "You did everything out of love. You're so loving, Katsuki. I think you're the fiercest, most protective person I've ever met. You deserve everything you want and *more* and it's okay to want it. Despite what you've done—Chizome should be *dead* for what he did to you and your mother."

Katsuki let out a shaky sigh. "You're the only one who seems to think that."

"I think your supervisor thinks it too," Izuku muttered. "But he is protecting you because he cares about you. Maybe you shouldn't kill Chizome yourself—but that man deserves his karma. And there are other ways."

Katsuki held onto Izuku's wrists tighter upon hearing that.

"Do…Do you care about me?" Katsuki asked.

"I more than care about you," Izuku whispered vulnerably.

'I love you,' is what he wanted to say but he kept the words close to his chest.

"I-I've cared about you since we were kids and I don't think I could ever stop," Izuku confessed. "Even in the years apart, I cared about you as the guy I met in Vienna. I will probably care about you even when my ankle heals and we go our separate ways." Slowly, Izuku leaned in and placed a delicate, light kiss on Katsuki's forehead. "You're not a monster. You're human."

"But I can't even be soft," Katsuki muttered. He shuffled in closely, trapping Izuku in his long limbs again. "No matter how hard I try I always hurt everyone I touch."

Izuku almost laughed at such a ridiculous statement.

"You're soft with me," Izuku said easily with a smile.

But Katsuki immediately seemed baffled, as if he never considered it. Izuku realized Katsuki's view of himself was heavily distorted so he decided to list all the beautiful moments they shared so far.

"I-I may not have spent a lot of time with you like others, but you're so soft with me." Izuku grinned affectionately and joy radiated through his smile. "You were soft when we were kids. You were soft at the hotel when you tried to pretend to be my husband. You were soft on the boat. On the beach. While hiking."

Izuku's face blushed slightly and his voice dropped into a quieter tone. "…Even in bed, you took care of me so nicely even though I was nervous. And even in the last month, you've been very soft with me."

Izuku wanted to mention more.

The truce from several years ago. That time Katsuki helped him escape out of the city. Even when they were in Vienna, Katsuki was soft. There were so many countless moments Izuku cherished in his memories that contradicted what Katsuki thought of himself.

"You can be soft, Katsuki," Izuku concluded with a gentle smile.

Izuku's words seemed to reach Katsuki and realization dawned on his face the same time the sun did. Golden light poured all over the room, lighting up everything.

They sat there for a moment, staring into each other's eyes. It was as if a new door was unlocked as they did this. Several lines were crossed and Izuku swallowed when his heart hammered out of control.

Slowly, Katsuki leaned in and kissed him.

This kiss was vastly different. It was deep and slow like Katsuki was taking his time mending their souls together. Like a needle and thread being woven in and out of him, Izuku felt his heart bind to Katsuki's.

Second Month of Honeymoon

The nursery changed their dynamic in a specific way. Katsuki showed his darkest parts and Izuku embraced the shadows with open arms. After that, they worked together to renovate the room into Katsuki's personal music study in perfect tandem. It represented his second chance at life, and with that clean slate came a new sort of air to Katsuki.

Izuku knew Katsuki could be soft, but he didn't know he could be so loving. Every action Katsuki did now was loaded with tenderness beyond what Izuku thought he deserved. It was hard to accept. Him, a born killer raised to slit throats, being showered in such pureness.

The pureness was in everyday things like doing the laundry. Or grocery shopping. Even when Katsuki started his music composition classes, Katsuki loved having him nearby just because.

The tiny domestic moments were so lovely. Izuku had no clue two people could simply live together in harmony like this.

Above all, one of Izuku's favorite things was when they brushed their teeth side by side.

It was silly when he said it out loud, but he couldn't help but find it to be fun.

The bathroom was built with two twin sinks and a large mirror. Every time they brushed their teeth they playfully bumped their hips or Katsuki would ruffle his hair. Today was no different.

Or at least, it wasn't until Izuku caught a glimpse of himself in the mirror.

He paused, leaned in, and noted there was a new freckle right below his eye. The spot overlapped with another making a sloppy, lopsided heart. It made Izuku unhappily churn. He lowered his eyes before he could get too disgruntled.

Katsuki stopped brushing his teeth and cut his eyes towards Izuku. He rinsed out his mouth with a hard gurgle and faced his way.

"Why do you do that?" Katsuki suddenly asked.

Izuku rinsed out his mouth and looked up innocently. "Do what?"

"Every time you look in the mirror you look away quickly." Katsuki frowned. "I haven't seen you look in the mirror longer than three seconds since we've been here."

Izuku blinked. "Oh. That."

"Yes. *That*." Katsuki raised a brow.

Izuku glanced off to the side. He nervously dragged his finger against the counter as he spoke his next words.

"I…I don't like looking at myself," Izuku whispered, feeling ashamed.

Katsuki frowned and cocked his head as if Izuku said pigs could fly. "Why not? You're beautiful, Izuku."

"I-It's not that, it's—" Izuku sucked in a breath when his insecurities started to sting.

"What?"

"My freckles," Izuku blurted out. He couldn't lift his head as his heart sang a low tune. "I know I told you about my mother that night in the nursery, but I…I didn't tell you the reason why. She said she found it hard to look at me because of my freckles. All I see when I look at my skin is a hundred little reasons why I wasn't given the chance to be loved."

Katsuki grew sad. "So you can't find your freckles beautiful anymore because of that?"

“I never found them beautiful in the first place.”

“…C’mere.”

Izuku was pulled out of his self-hatred when Katsuki stepped forward and cupped his face with both hands. Like steady rain, Katsuki began peppering kisses all along his cheeks, chin, and nose bridge. The whiplash of it left Izuku confused as he was given what felt like a dozen tiny love pecks.

Katsuki pulled back and looked into Izuku’s eyes.

“This is about to be the mushiest shit I ever said so no laughing,” Katsuki fore-warned with a slight glower. “But I won’t stand for all this self-deprecation.”

He turned Izuku to face the mirror and tilted his chin up. Izuku inched his gaze up to face their reflection. He saw them neatly together like a real married couple and it made his heart thump.

Katsuki’s expression then melted into pure adoration. He gently kissed the top of Izuku’s cheek bone where the new, heart-shaped freckle was.

“All I see when I look at your freckles is you,” Katsuki muttered as if he was trying his best to be soft with his words. “A hundred little reasons why I adore you and more stare back at me.”

That was probably the sweetest thing ever said to him.

Izuku’s heart melted. “I’m starting to question which one of us is the sappy romantic.”

“That’s still you,” Katsuki quipped with no bite. “But did you know the freckles on your back look like miniature constellations?”

Izuku raised his brows. “Really?”

“Mhm.” Katsuki lightly touched his shoulder and fiddled with his shirt. “Can I?”

Izuku nodded apprehensively.

Katsuki slid the oversized sleep shirt off Izuku’s shoulders to expose his back. It pooled at his hips, and as if he was made of stars himself, Katsuki carefully turned him around. Izuku’s heart raced as he looked over his shoulder into the mirror.

With his calloused fingers, Katsuki traced out the Little Dipper, Big Dipper, and the rabbit constellation inside Izuku’s back muscles. He took his time and admired the pathways he drew as if he really saw nebulas shimmering.

“How about every day I give you a kiss until I give you one for every freckle you have?”

“But I have new ones pop up all the time.”

“Then I guess I’m gonna have to kiss you forever.”

The promise of ‘forever’ hung over their heads and contradicted their predicament. Izuku looked at Katsuki, and even Katsuki was stunned by what he said. Izuku waited for him to retract the statement or make an amendment. But he didn’t.

Instead Katsuki smiled like he truly did mean what he said.

He gave Izuku’s shoulder a chaste kiss.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku looked at his freckles a little differently after that. Not entirely without the years of hatred he held for them, but now he saw the promise of forever hidden inside of them. When the next freckle showed up, he viewed it as a future kiss from Katsuki. He smiled and was able to look at himself a little longer.

The days began to melt away again and Izuku found himself in awe at how attentive Katsuki was. He cooked, cleaned, kissed him and watched every single movie Izuku loved. Izuku thought it couldn’t get any better than this.

Or at least he thought that until he was given the ultimate gift: a scene straight out of his favorite novel.

He didn’t catch on at first. Katsuki ran him a bath and when Izuku stumbled upon it, he staggered. It was exactly like his favorite book. But there was no way Katsuki knew that.

The lights in the bathroom were dimmed half way down, and the fragrance of various herbs filled the air. When he caught sight of the rose petals on top of the water and the candles, Izuku thought maybe he was drawing false conclusions.

But then Katsuki informed him that the bath was only for him.

Just like in the book.

Izuku finished the bath, put on the white silk robe that was hung up neatly on the towel hanger, and then he hobbled out to go find Katsuki. But as he walked, he found a trail of rose petals littered across the floor. His heart fluttered in disbelief and he slowly followed the path all the way out into the living room.

What was waiting for him was a scene he had read a thousand times over.

Directly in front of the fireplace was Katsuki, the man of his dreams. He was draped in a black robe with a white rose in his mouth. His sinful eyes captured the reflection of the fireplace as he laid on top of three layers of blankets. Beside him was a small line of soft pillows and cushions on the outer edges.

And rose petals were thrown everywhere.

“Kacchan?” Izuku called out.

Katsuki perked up and quickly he snapped into place like an actor ready for his role. While keeping eye contact, he slowly raked a hand through his hair while holding the rose between his teeth seductively.

“Wh-What is all this?” Izuku asked as he finally drew closer. He tried to soak it in, but he was in disbelief at what he was witnessing. Once he stood directly in front of Katsuki, there was no choice but to accept the truth. “This…This is exactly—this is the same as—”

“—Yes, it’s the same as your book,” Katsuki said. He took the rose out of his mouth and twirled it around. “It’s the scene after the mountain passage when they finally make it home. I read it all. *Twice*.” Katsuki’s grin widened. “I can see why you enjoy that part so much.”

Izuku was stunned into silence. He stood there, trying to comprehend that anti-romantic Katsuki was reenacting a scene from a romance novel. *Willingly*. Without a gun to his head.

Izuku slowly descended from his crutches down to Katsuki’s level. He carefully caressed a rose petal as if it was made of glass and picked it up.

This was the nicest thing anyone ever did for him—and he felt so bitter sweet about it. He always wanted love, but deep in the back of his mind he knew why he never pursued it like Hiryu. Izuku didn’t believe he deserved it. Yet here Katsuki was, giving it all to him.

“Do you like it?” Katsuki asked wearily. “If you don’t I can put this all away, and we can go to bed—”

“—No, I really love this,” Izuku whispered. His voice cracked on the ends, and his eyes were glossy. “Th-This is exactly how I pictured the scene. Everything is perfect, I-I can’t believe you did this.”

“I’m glad you like it,” Katsuki said quietly. He licked his lips, leaned in, and placed a warm hand on Izuku’s exposed thigh. “I…I would do this again if…it meant…seeing you smile.”

Izuku felt his heart jump to new heights.

“I thought you hated anything to do with romance?” Izuku asked softly.

“I guess it’s different when it comes to you.”

Katsuki handed Izuku the white rose and the wedding ring on his hand glimmered.

Izuku took the rose and the love inside of his heart for Katsuki doubled. Then it tripled. Then it multiplied so much that Izuku had no more measurements to express how much he truly did love Katsuki.

“Thank you so much,” Izuku whispered. The words ‘*I love you*’ burned him from the inside out. “This is the nicest thing anyone has done for me.”

Katsuki wordlessly smiled at him, picked up the two wine glasses, and handed one to Izuku. Izuku blushed deeply as he indulged in this romantic fantasy. He drank from the glass while maintaining eye contact with Katsuki.

When the bitter taste hit the back of his throat, Izuku choked a bit.

“What’s wrong?” Katsuki asked after swallowing.

Izuku wiped his mouth with the back of his hand. He started laughing and swirled the wine in the glass. “I don’t like the taste of red wine. I thought I would get used to it—but I guess I never have.”

Katsuki laughed from his stomach gorgeously and Izuku laughed too. So much for playing it exactly word for word. Their laughter mixed together in a chorus of joy as Katsuki shook his head. He took a couple big gulps of his drink before taking Izuku’s wine glass in his hand. He set them aside and smirked mirthfully.

“Let’s cut to the main part then,” Katsuki said with a hint of playfulness. “Not everything has to be done by the book.”

Izuku gripped the white rose tightly, knowing what was going to come next.

Katsuki shifted on the blankets and leaned in to grab Izuku by the waist. He dragged Izuku closer effortlessly and the heat in the room grew thicker.

“This is where the lovers intertwine,” Katsuki whispered as he undid the sash of Izuku’s robe. “They lose their virginity to the other, and they take it really slow and become forever bonded.” Katsuki kissed the tattoo on Izuku’s collar. “In sickness.” Another small kiss on his heart shaped freckle. “And in health.” A caress of the skin. “Until death do they part.”

Izuku’s breathing quickened, and his core spiked with taboo desire.

“Are you nervous again?” Katsuki muttered directly against Izuku’s lips. He smirked mischievously. “I promise I’ll make sure I’m gentle. I know how delicate virgins can be.”

“I’m not a virgin anymore,” Izuku quipped quickly, having a small visceral reaction to the word ‘virgin’. “And I’m not delicate.”

“I know. But c’mon, let me enjoy this.” Katsuki chuckled lightly and stole a kiss. “Still can’t get over my handsome virginal husband who waited until marriage for me all these damn years.”

Well. When it was put like that, Izuku found it romantic. He smiled at the thought and blushed at the title of husbands. Izuku laughed lightly and reddened when he found himself wanting to hear it again.

“Katsuki. You’re making me feel embarrassed calling me your husband.”

“Do you not like being called that? Husband suits you.”

Katsuki's voice dropped several octaves and Izuku squirmed. Hearing Katsuki refer to him as 'husband' fed a specific side of Izuku, one that he tried so hard not to indulge too much. This was simply a role-play but it was blurring a fine line between make believe and what Izuku always wanted in real life.

He felt himself grow increasingly excited at the thought of being married to Katsuki.

Slyly, Katsuki glanced down and noticed Izuku's cock growing hard and he grinned.

"You really fuckin' seem like you're enjoying it," Katsuki noted.

"I-I am," Izuku whispered shyly.

He was teetering on the edge of a forbidden line as he thought about potentially being married to Katsuki in all seriousness. After the last few weeks, he wouldn't mind it. In fact, he *wanted* to be wed to Katsuki. That thought scared him because he probably was alone in wanting that.

Izuku whispered, "You don't think it's odd considering we are legally married by accident? It feels taboo to use it like this."

"We're alone, who will judge us?" Katsuki questioned.

Katsuki snaked a hand underneath Izuku's robe to teasingly rub the inside of his soft, freckled thigh. The sensation soothed all Izuku's over thinking as he was tempted down yet another dangerous pathway.

"No one," Izuku said breathlessly.

"Exactly."

Izuku's eyes fluttered closed as Katsuki's hand snuck closer to his erection.

"If you like it, I can call you my husband in bed." Katsuki brushed their noses together. "This is between us, it's private and intimate. You're my darling husband right now and I'm yours."

Izuku nodded hesitantly and decided maybe Katsuki was right. He closed his eyes and allowed his body to loosen up all the way. He fell head first into Katsuki's temptation happily. He dropped the rose off to the side and wrapped his arms around Katsuki's neck. They kissed deeply, tongues sliding across each other sweetly.

"Try saying it," Katsuki said into the kiss. "Call me your husband."

"Y-You're my husband," Izuku whispered.

"And I'm going to take such good fucking care of you tonight," Katsuki rasped hungrily. "*Bakugou* Izuku."

A fiery need consumed Izuku's every waking thought as he gave into his forbidden fantasies. It gave him a deep satisfaction to acknowledge his current surname was the name of the man

he loved.

Just like in the book, their bodies caramelized together in a perfect simmering molding. It was lovely in every way Izuku remembered from his first time. Each kiss, stroke, and lingering caress lit his nerve endings a blaze. He indulged in the scorching feeling, more than willing to be burned alive by Katsuki's passion.

Izuku moaned softly into their joined mouths as their body heat swelled. Every kiss Katsuki planted on his skin was given with delicate care. Izuku was stunned at how vastly different this time was from the first as Katsuki handled him with expert tenderness.

But he accepted it all the same, always willing and ready to take Katsuki in.

Katsuki worked him open with just as much care as before and sweet love trickled across Izuku's body. The slow burn of ecstasy hit his core like a meteorite searing into the earth. As if Katsuki knew every inch of his skin, he hit all the right spots in an instant.

Izuku reached his peak immediately with the way Katsuki hit deep with pressure at just the right spot. Not once did Katsuki's burning gaze look away as Izuku came and when he slid Izuku on his lap, an unexpected heartstring tugged inside of Izuku.

Katsuki looked at him like he was everything as he slowly lowered him down onto his cock.

Izuku relished the addictive feeling of being stretched wide open. Every thrust Katsuki gave was filled with need and Izuku ground down with just as much longing. The slow build of their pleasure took a hold of him as they rocked back and forth. They were face to face and chest to chest with every push and pull as bliss built.

Their motion drew out combinations of emotions Izuku didn't think was possible. Need melted with ecstasy. Longing mixed with devotion. Bottomless ruin meshed with yearning.

Both of their bodies shook together as the waves came crashing down on them.

Izuku cried out in a broken, high pitched moan when he peaked a second time. He came harshly into Katsuki's fist at the same time Katsuki snapped his hips in a perfect, precise motion against his sweet spot.

Witnessing Katsuki's orgasm was a gift Izuku would never forget.

He seized up fully, and his mouth dropped open as he came harshly inside of him. A throaty groan spilled into the air as he buried himself to the hilt and locked their bodies together.

Tiny rose petals stuck to their skin and Izuku wished he could capture this moment forever.

"That was so amazing," Izuku mumbled, entirely dazed.

Izuku's hands intertwined with Katsuki's. He laid a simple kiss on top of his husband's wedding band.

“Did you like it soft like that?” Katsuki asked. His chest heaved as he kept Izuku trapped in his arms. “I tried my best to make sure I was gentle.”

“I did, that was different in a good way,” Izuku said happily.

“I can keep doing that for you, if you enjoy it more than me being rough.” Katsuki smiled and drew tiny hearts on Izuku’s skin. “I should’ve done this for your first time and made you feel all special and shit.”

“I liked it the way we did it before too,” Izuku clarified. He squeezed Katsuki’s hand in his reassuringly. “I wouldn’t have changed how I had my first experience because I had it with you. That’s all I really wanted, Kacchan. I don’t mind either way as long as your lips are on mine.”

Katsuki seemed surprised. “Really?”

“Mhm.” Izuku grinned. “I especially like it when your hands are on me—” Izuku paused and guided Katsuki’s hand up to his neck. He assisted in clasping the large fingers tightly around his throat until it was a near perfect necklace. “—*like this*. I have more than one type of fantasy but they’re all involving *you*.”

He felt Katsuki’s cock inside of him jump back to life. His husband didn’t remove his hand and his eyes were boring into Izuku so intensely.

“What else have you been interested in?” Katsuki asked carefully like he was in a trance.

Izuku bit his lip shyly.

He thought back on a memory where Jin said he experienced an encounter that changed his life. His older brother had come back from the Circle of Lust one day right before their family dinner. He was blissfully dazed and mentioned he engaged in a session with a dominatrix who he claimed changed his brain chemistry.

He went to see her several times after that. But that day he mentioned something that always had Izuku curious.

“…Have you ever heard of edging?” Izuku carefully asked.

A dark, sharp chuckle escaped from Katsuki. His husband gave a depraved smile and happily choked Izuku lightly, pulling him by his neck to draw his lips close.

“We’re about to have a lot of fucking fun. Aren’t we?” Katsuki nearly growled.

Izuku nodded and raked his nails down Katsuki’s back. They shared another heated kiss as Katsuki clasped his hand firmer while moving their lips together.

In the comfort of this bubble, Izuku allowed himself to believe they were truly happily married.

After that it was like a floodgate of desire was opened and out poured all their craving. Their skin was pressed together constantly and both soft and rough touches were exchanged. Izuku felt like he was a whole new person. How could one man have this much influence over him?

Every time Katsuki so much as looked at him, weakness hit the back of Izuku's knees like a baseball bat.

He found himself frequently on all fours moaning and getting happily fucked. If he wasn't on his side, back, or belly, he happily was on his knees with a cock down his throat. It was difficult at first given Katsuki's size, but once he got the hang of it, Izuku wanted to taste Katsuki until the essence of him was permanently soaked into his tongue.

He'd do anything for this man.

Which is why when Katsuki plopped down a cardboard box in front of him on their bed, Izuku became intrigued.

"What's in there?" Izuku asked when his husband didn't make a move to open it.

The mischievous smile pinned on Katsuki's handsome face grew brighter. Then he said, "A shit ton of sex toys."

Izuku spluttered. "S-Sex toys?"

He straightened his back, completely caught off guard and blood burned at his cheeks.

"And other things," Katsuki tacked on.

Katsuki reached down and finally opened up the box. Izuku was astonished. Staring right back at him was an absurd amount of candy g-strings, rope, and all different kinds of dildos, plugs and vibrators. But one thing made Izuku burn with embarrassment.

"Is that doughnut flavored lube?" Izuku chastised.

Katsuki nodded with a snicker and Izuku nearly threw his slipper at him.

"I thought it would be fun to use given our little baking incident." Katsuki laughed. "Plus, you would have the most delicious cream-pie if we used this. You wouldn't be able to keep my mouth off you."

Izuku's cheeks burned. "You really love cream pies, don't you?"

"They're one of the *sweetest* joys of life."

"When did you even buy all of this?" Izuku asked.

"When I went out shopping the other day," Katsuki answered. "I stopped in a sex store. I was only trying to buy lube, but when I was in there I realized there might be things you could

enjoy. I figured we could try some stuff out. I would *really* love to take care of you while you explore different sexual things."

Shyness crept its way in as Katsuki began to unpack the box. His husband neatly laid out all of the various toys and items for Izuku to see in a straight line. He placed a heart shaped plug between the bright red rope and scented massage oil.

Izuku suddenly felt excited but deeply nervous. He wanted to try things with Katsuki but he lowered his head a bit as he looked at all the toys. He began to question his level of experience when he saw something that looked like a string of beads. What would that even be for?

Katsuki seemed to notice this and paused his organization. He reached out to tenderly stroke Izuku's leg.

"Or we don't have to," Katsuki quickly added, fully sincere. "I just figured you might like some of this stuff, but we don't have to do anything you're not comfortable with. We can take it at your pace and explore however you want. Don't feel any pressure."

"I want to," Izuku said. "I-I'm just not sure where to start?"

"Pick something," Katsuki said softly. "We'll start wherever you feel most comfortable."

Izuku bit his lip as he looked at everything splayed across their bed. He figured starting with something he was familiar with would be good. With full confidence, Izuku pointed to the red rope.

Katsuki's eyebrows shot up a bit, but then a wicked grin settled onto his lips.

"Great choice there, darling. Let's get started with this tonight."

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku squirmed in anticipation on the couch.

They were feet away from the fireplace and it was the dead of night now. All around them the windows were closed and not a single noise interrupted their moment. Izuku had been stripped naked of all his clothes, and so had Katsuki.

Katsuki was standing in front of him, cock directly in Izuku's face. It was erect and hanging low by the force of gravity. Izuku bit his lip as he studied all the bulging veins and his tongue twisted with the urge to latch himself on to it.

Katsuki glanced down at him and slowly began to stroke himself. He pushed the tip to Izuku's mouth, smearing a trail of pre-cum across the plump lips. Izuku's tongue darted out to taste and Katsuki groaned at the sight.

"Do you wanna give a quick suck, darling?" Katsuki asked.

Izuku nodded eagerly. He opened his mouth, happy to accept his husband in. The action amused Katsuki as he inched forward to drag his tip against Izuku's awaiting, wet tongue.

Izuku moved his head down the length, and the sheer thickness of his husband filled him up as he began to graciously suck. Katsuki groaned at the sensation and buried his hands into Izuku's head of curls. He gently pushed his cock in further. Immediately, Izuku adjusted his jaw to be wider. He bobbed his head sensually, inching Katsuki's cock further and further back into his mouth until the hot tip hit the back of his throat.

Katsuki began to move his head for him, thrusting in slowly.

"Get it nice and wet, darling," Katsuki groaned. "Suck it like you want me to fuck you with it."

At that, Izuku was inspired. He pushed his thighs together when heat suddenly spilled into his belly. He bobbed his head quicker and whined when Katsuki gripped the base of his curls with vigor. Izuku hallowed out his cheeks, drawing out a deep curse from his husband as he swirled his tongue around. He sucked harder and slowly Katsuki's cock sank into his throat.

The sound Katsuki made from this was marvelous. He staggered a bit, amazed as Izuku deepthroated him eagerly. He then used both hands to grip Izuku's head and slowly sank his girth into the tight, wet, passage over and over. Izuku felt himself get turned on by the erotic sounds of his husband above him. Hearts were surely dancing in his eyes and Katsuki began to stroke his hair and praise him.

"Damn, you're a quick learner," Katsuki moaned.

He rocked his hips lightly as Izuku pulled back and gave a long, wet suck. He began to get more into it, and lifted his hands. With both, he twisted the base of Katsuki's girth and the kitten licked the tip. Upon hearing a moan, Izuku began to blow Katsuki exactly like he was taught. He defaulted to sucking and pumping, and above him Katsuki was groaning and cursing.

The hot length in his mouth throbbed and Izuku squirmed as he tried to take Katsuki back down his throat. But he was stopped when Katsuki let out a loud curse and quickly snapped his head back by his hair. Izuku gasped at the sudden movement and a dribble of spit slid down his chin.

Katsuki let out a shaky breath and stared down at Izuku with wide, dilated eyes.

"Good fuckin' boy," Katsuki praised. "I think you definitely deserve to get cock after that."

Izuku keened as Katsuki manhandled him beautifully. He was careful with his body, and made sure not to bump or agitate his broken bones. Izuku was tenderly flipped on his belly and above him, Katsuki straddled him with one leg on the couch and the other off to give him leverage.

Katsuki then reached for the rope that was laying on the ground.

All of Izuku's sensations spiked in anticipation.

"Have you fantasized about tying me up often?" Izuku cheekily questioned.

He peeked over his shoulder to stare up at his husband. Immediately, a chill ran down his spine at the sight of Katsuki looming over him with his giant cock hanging down. Katsuki tested the tension of the rope with a sharp tug in both hands.

"I think we both know the answer to that one, *Deku*," Katsuki teased.

He gazed down at Izuku in a way that was loaded with heat. With both hands, Katsuki forced Izuku's arms behind his back and his calloused fingers dug into the supple skin. Izuku squirmed, every touch felt magnified to new extremes already. When his elbows touched behind his back, the tension added on to his growing arousal like a stack of heavy bricks inside of him.

It only took a moment for Katsuki to wrap one of his hands around both of his wrists to hold him tight. *Large*. That was Izuku's first thought. His second thought was how tightly Katsuki was restraining him and his cock began to twitch to life.

He drank in the way the rope felt against his skin. There was a burn to it that teetered between interesting and uncomfortable. It made him dangerously curious. Next, his breath hitched as Katsuki fastened the rope around his wrists and up his forearms like a red snake binding to his flesh.

Izuku closed his eyes as he felt Katsuki tie a double knot. Then a triple and there was some other sort of intricate knot made that he couldn't make out without seeing.

Curiously, Izuku experimentally tugged his wrists apart to test the strength. He could barely budge. A strange, new type of satisfaction rattled in Izuku's core and his cock grew fully hard.

"This is very secure," Izuku praised and blinked a couple of times. "Much better than that one time you tried to tie me up."

Katsuki barked out a sharp laugh and said, "Don't even get me started on how mad I was that you got away that day."

His smile transformed into a feral smirk as he reached down and viciously pulled Izuku up on his knees. Izuku choked a bit, surprised at Katsuki's strength as he was forced backwards on his hunches. Katsuki continued to wrap the rope up Izuku's arms and circled it several times across his chest in an intricate design.

"I couldn't believe you wiggled your way out, I was so sure I caught you," Katsuki said as he made a couple more knots. The material grazed across Izuku's sensitive nipples and he bit his lip when a tingle of pleasure spilled down his body. "After that I spent *days* in my room fuming and practicing tying knots so that next time I caught you—" Katsuki fastened the rope with a fierce tug. "—You couldn't run away from me."

The way Katsuki said that last bit was like warm honey in the throat. Smooth, slow, and sweet in a dark way.

He glanced down at his chest and marveled at Katsuki's handiwork. It was beautiful. He moved slightly and with the way Katsuki criss-crossed the rope it stimulated his nipples with every movement. Izuku let out a shaky breath as he began to get stimulated.

"I don't, ah, think these are the types of knots you tie to capture your enemy," Izuku said when he nearly moaned from the sensation on his chest.

"They are when you were my enemy," Katsuki said huskily.

He finished tying the rope and pressed his chest against Izuku's back. He slowly dragged his hands up and down Izuku's thighs, making Izuku shutter at the feeling. Izuku relaxed fully onto Katsuki when his rough hands began kneading into him.

Katsuki leaned down and ghosted his mouth over Izuku's jugular.

"Y'know, I used to have this fantasy," Izuku breathlessly confessed. He licked his lips as Katsuki gently sucked at his neck. "I-I used to imagine there would be a day where you finally caught me, and when you did…you, ah, would fuck me."

Katsuki paused.

He slowly turned Izuku's head to look at him and there was a profound hunger in his eyes.

"Surprise to hear that, not going to lie," Katsuki said. "But I admittedly have a similar one. I used to dream about the day I finally got you in my hands. I tried to tell myself I would kill you, but really, I know it would end with us having brutal hate sex."

Izuku's cock twitched at the idea.

What a missed opportunity. Too bad they didn't have any more shared animosity.

"Maybe when your ankle is better we can role-play that," Katsuki suggested. "Until then, let's focus on this. If there's ever a moment you want out of the rope, say so, okay?" Katsuki muttered against his skin.

Izuku nodded. "Okay, I will."

At that validation, Katsuki dragged his hands up to touch Izuku's soft nipples.

The feeling pulsed down his chest, and Izuku softly moaned when Katsuki used his thumbs to rub circles on top of them. He pinched them greedily and pulled them slowly. Izuku arched his back when one hard tug made his cock ache. He moved out of reflex to grab at his erection but was met with the burning sensation of rope and groaned low.

Katsuki moved like he had nowhere to be. He played with his chest and sucked at his neck, dragging long sensational touches up and down. He put one hand by Izuku's mouth and

pushed in his fingers lightly as he twirled one hard bud in his other hand. Izuku happily took the fingers in his mouth and graciously sucked on them, wetting them.

He breathed out heavily through his nose when he felt another wave of erotic pleasure trickle through him. Katsuki removed his fingers from his mouth with a wet pop and used them to slowly circle the hard nipple on Izuku's chest.

Izuku tried rocking back on Katsuki and slowly Katsuki's hand sank lower and lower until he grabbed for Izuku's hard on. Izuku moaned slowly as his husband pumped him long and teasingly. The heat from Katsuki's palm wrapped him and Izuku whined as he tried to thrust into the fist.

Katsuki then moved his other hand downwards to Izuku's backside.

He carefully maneuvered him forwards and spread his legs across the couch cushions. Izuku heard the tiny sound of a cap clicking as Katsuki worked behind him. Next the wet tantalizing sensation of a finger coated with slick lube rubbed at his entrance at the same time Katsuki gave his cock a generous pump. Izuku groaned as Katsuki pushed his way in with one finger and pumped it.

Izuku moaned in a way he would be ashamed of later when Katsuki pushed in two fingers and softly pushed against his prostate. The pleasure gripped him instantly. Izuku gasped and dropped his head as he was stimulated from both ends.

Katsuki pushed into Izuku mercilessly at different angles until he found the right one that made him groan the loudest.

"Feeling' good?" Katsuki whispered against the shell of his ear.

The words added to the growing flame and Izuku nodded eagerly. "I-I am."

"You're about to feel even better."

Izuku's stomach flipped, and the feeling of electricity raced down to his toes. Katsuki quickened his movements, egged on by Izuku's breathing. Izuku rocked his body back and forth between the two overwhelming sensations and the rope cut across his sensitive chest.

He jerked when his belly coiled more and Katsuki pumped him quicker. He fucked his fingers directly against his sweet spot and Izuku's thighs began quaking from waves of pleasure. His mouth dropped in a tiny 'o' shape as he felt the burn inside of him grow into an overwhelming storm.

"Ka-Kacchan," Izuku whispered. "A-Ah—I think I'm going to cum."

He struggled against the rope but found himself restricted. And that just made him groan in pleasure more. He was at Katsuki's mercy and he loved the thought.

"Yeah?" Katsuki groaned and ground into him from behind, forcing his fingers deeper to milk Izuku's prostate. "You gonna cum for me, *darling*?"

Izuku nodded with a breathy moan and ground back on the fingers as Katsuki slipped a third in. The fullness of three digits was like liquid lightning. His legs shook with euphoria and his back bent into an arch. His orgasm climbed and climbed as Katsuki finger fucked him and pumped his throbbing cock faster. The pleasure raked across his nipples, back, arms, and toes.

And right when the elation compiled to topple over into nirvana—

—Katsuki removed his fingers.

Izuku groaned at the whiplash as the pleasure in his body retreated. It left behind an empty burning sensation that was close to the feeling of coals on the inside of his stomach. In a desperate attempt to follow his orgasm, Izuku jerked forward and just like that, he sent himself toppling down on the couch. Izuku tried to move to touch himself again but was reminded once more he didn't have the use of his hands.

"You really thought it would be that easy tonight?" Katsuki darkly chuckled.

Izuku tried to grind into the cushion and Katsuki shot a hand out to grab the rope. The world Izuku saw was flipped as he was laid on his back, legs wide open. Katsuki looked more than pleased with him as he spread Izuku's legs wider and took his rightful place in them.

Izuku felt nearly lightheaded from the orgasm denial.

"Kacchan," Izuku said his lover's name like it was his lifeline. He arched his back off the couch and unwillingly his body twitched at the friction of the rope rubbing his chest. "Pl-Please let me cum."

Katsuki 'tched' as he rubbed the thick head of his cock against Izuku's hole. Izuku spread his legs further, waiting for it to be pushed in but instead Katsuki only lightly placed it at his entrance. He leaned over Izuku with his sharp-toothed grin.

"I don't think so," Katsuki chastised in a low voice. "I'm going to make you crazy for it. Now *beg*, Izuku."

"I-I need you," Izuku moaned. "I want you in me so badly, please."

Izuku felt himself flutter as Katsuki pushed his cock into him. The tip opened him up and caught on his rim. The delicious sensation radiated a promise of unfathomable pleasure and Izuku sighed and spread his legs more.

But then Katsuki's pulled right back out.

Izuku groaned loudly from the back of his throat as Katsuki did it again and again, sinking in further each time. Izuku began squirming and whined when the tip barely brushed his sweet spot.

"That was a weak ass plea. Try again." Katsuki darkly chuckled.

“Split me open,” Izuku said with a moan mixed in. He arched his back and stared straight into Katsuki’s eyes. “Fuck me until I see stars I’m begging, *please*. I-I need you so much. I need your cock.”

“You sound like you’re about to lose it,” Katsuki groaned.

“I-I might,” Izuku said helplessly. “I need the feeling of you giving it to me.”

Katsuki bit his lip. “You love being filled up don’t you?”

“I love being filled up *by you*.”

He knew that was the chord to strike to make his possessive husband go as mad as him. As expected, Katsuki’s expression became overwhelmed with lust and he began to stroke Izuku’s cock.

The large hand practically swallowed his length whole and it tightly wrapped around the base. Ripples of fervor stacked on top of Izuku’s denied orgasm, bringing him back to the top quickly. Izuku didn’t understand what was happening as every pleasurable sensation doubled then tripled as Katsuki finally sank in deep enough to push against his prostate.

The pleasure inside of him swelled at the seams and so did the desperation this time. He clenched down on the slick girth inside of him as Katsuki finally buried himself to the hilt. Izuku shuddered when his husband rolled his hips, pushing directly against that spot that made him lose his mind.

Katsuki moved to lift Izuku’s legs over his shoulders and carefully held his cast still. He then tightly held the other leg in a vice grip. With no warning, Katsuki reeled back and thrusted back in sharply, immediately setting a pace that was fast and brutal. Every thrust was punctuated with hitting Izuku’s sweet spot, pouring more and more pleasure over his body.

Stars scattered across Izuku’s vision as he was fucked with purpose. He whimpered and tried to push back against the cock driving into his tight hole.

Flickers of addictive heat bloomed inside of him again as Katsuki kept his pace. He gained momentum with every powerful thrust, and began lifting Izuku’s hips as he fucked him with intense force. Izuku threw his head back as his breathing skipped and his chest convulsed. Katsuki leaned forward, not stopping his hips, and rolled both of Izuku’s nipples underneath his thumbs and gave them both a light flick.

Izuku’s legs immediately quaked and he arched into the feeling.

“*Damn*,” Katsuki cursed low as he pounded into Izuku. “Every time I play with them, you clench around me, it feels so damn addictive.”

Izuku couldn’t find the words to respond. Instead a small litany of moans, pleas, and loose syllables of Katsuki’s name poured from him. He screwed his eyes shut as Katsuki continued to roll his sensitive buds under his fingers again. Izuku twitched with a moan and Katsuki ground his hips against Izuku, pushing his cock deeper.

With every thrust Izuku climbed higher and higher until his voice began to climb too. His lips quivered when his mind was drowned in the feeling of Katsuki everywhere. The coil tightened inside of him again and several wonton pleas escaped. The tension inside of his core spiked and he clenched down on the thick length inside of him as his own cock began to spasm.

Then as quickly as it built, it left and Katsuki swiftly pulled all the way out.

Izuku nearly sobbed as Katsuki none-too-gently buried inside him again in one swift motion, The ledge he was teetering on was intense and he felt his orgasm rise and fall like a flood. He begged for it to be let out as he tried to grind down but Katsuki kept him perfectly balanced at the intensity of his peak. But he never allowed him to reach it fully.

“Isn’t this what you wanted?” Katsuki teased as he began to slowly fuck Izuku. “Edged to the end of oblivion by your husband’s cock?”

“Ye-yes,” Izuku nearly cried.

Katsuki thrusted his hips and punched out a gasp from Izuku. “Say it *louder*.”

“*Yes*!” Izuku said with more force.

Katsuki reached for the rope splayed across Izuku’s chest and pulled, snapping Izuku on to him.

“Fuck!” Izuku nearly screamed as he threw his head back. “*Kacchan*!”

He was pulled back on Katsuki over and over. The delicious feeling built inside of him again and he found himself wiggling and moaning. And just like before, Katsuki kept him perfectly balanced between oblivion and searing pleasure.

Each time Izuku thought he was going to cum, he was denied. Every time Izuku thought they would slow down, he was wrong. All the push and pull Katsuki gave him made Izuku dive into a sea of rapture until all he could think about was Katsuki touching him and being inside of him.

“Ka-Kacchan,” Izuku sobbed. “Please. Please. Let me cum on your cock—”

His mind began buzzing as their speed picked up. The sheer force began to make his whole body tremble and the tension from his restraints dug into him. Long strips of pre-cum oozed out of Izuku’s tip and Katsuki reached down to stimulate his cock.

“You should see the way you’re dripping, darling,” Katsuki cooed.

Izuku’s world spun in an instant when his knees were pushed into his shoulders, perfectly folding him in a half. The hot pre-cum dripped on his stomach and from this angle Izuku could perfectly see the way Katsuki’s cock was splitting him open. It was absurdly lewd, and Izuku’s breath quickened at the sight of his hole perfectly wrapped around the veiny cock.

Katsuki doesn't let up as he slams into him from this angle, perfectly aligned with the spot that makes Izuku see the heavens. Izuku was a mess now. Sobbing, twitching and moaning as he is given the perfect view of himself getting fucked and his cock being fondled. The sound of their skin slapping together mixed with their breathy moans and Izuku couldn't take his eyes away from their joined bodies.

Then Katsuki gave in.

The tell-tale deep groan that Izuku learned to love spilled into the air. It was throaty and accompanying it was Katsuki's hips jerking with vigor. Izuku purposefully clenched his hole around Katsuki, and the reaction was instant. His husband's nostrils flared and his hand pumped Izuku vehemently.

"F-Fuck," Katsuki moaned. "You're so goddamn *tight*."

Izuku clenched again, and Katsuki fucks him harder. It's a mesmerizing sight to see the way Katsuki's cock disappears inside of him. Then with one more clench, Katsuki begins to desperately jerk him off. Izuku breathes like he's panicking as he finally feels himself reach higher to his peak and the promise of an orgasm is finally on the corner.

"You ready to cum now, darling?" Katsuki panted out shakily.

"Ye-Yes!" Izuku answered quickly. "Please! Please, Kacchan!"

Katsuki snapped his hips several more times and Izuku orgasmed first.

He moans loud enough that his voice cracks in two and his core tightens as his muscles spasm. The peak he reached felt like a compiled burst of all of the denied orgasms in one. It's a ruinous wave of oblivion that crashed down on him like nothing he felt before. The sensation seared into his soul and Izuku cried as his cock throbs with heat. Ribbons of his own warm, cum squirted across his chest, nipples, and face. He gasped at the tantalizing sensation.

Katsuki's intense gaze watched the whole thing. The sight of Izuku decorated in his own essence sends him directly over the edge.

Izuku feels his husband bury his cock impossibly deep inside of him and his hot cum fills him to the brim. Izuku gasped at how lovely it felt and subconsciously tightened around Katsuki to feel the radiating warmth. Katsuki groaned and grinded down as Izuku's body milked him of his seed. Katsuki's body shook as he tried to give several deep thrusts before he collapsed on top of Izuku.

It takes several beats of silence for them to get their barring.

Katsuki carefully slid out of Izuku but didn't move as he kept Izuku bent in half. He locked his hands around Izuku's knees and kept him where he was. He tentatively studied Izuku's hole that was dripping cum while Izuku was panting heavily.

Briefly, Izuku wondered what was going through Katsuki's head when his husband didn't make a move. He just watched Izuku's hole clench and unclench with the creamy liquid oozing out. It trickled down his backside and across his sack.

Suddenly, Katsuki's tongue shot out and gently licked his hole. Izuku jumped instantly.

"*Katsuki*," Izuku groaned, and his husband began to lick him again and again.

Katsuki breathed out through his nose as he buried his face further. He generously enjoyed the cream-pie of his husband at languid speed. He took his time and Izuku gasped at the flicker of over-stimulation that trickled down his spine when Katsuki gave a long, hard lap.

When Katsuki's tongue dove into him Izuku wiggled in his restraints as he began to be aroused back to life. The sensual way Katsuki's wet appendage massaged him and the obscene sounds of him swallowing filled the air. Izuku screwed his eyes shut as he endured the post-rapture sensation.

When Katsuki finished, he pulled back and gave Izuku's sack a suggestive flick of the tongue. Katsuki wolfishly grinned and Izuku knew he was damned.

A sex demon. He married a sex demon.

"Sorry," Katsuki said half heartedly as he wiped his mouth. "I couldn't resist that one."

He thumbed at Izuku's hole, letting him know he wasn't finished with him.

"Did you like the rope?" Katsuki asked, completely out of breath.

"I loved it," Izuku whispered back.

He stared at Katsuki's thumb that was gently applying pressure. A loving smile stretched across Katsuki's face as he moved his finger gingerly. His husband's eyes were beautifully dilated. Izuku knew his eyes were as well and they laughed lightly between each other.

"What's next in that box?" Izuku asked eagerly.

Katsuki grinned from ear to ear. "*So* fucking much. Do you think you could go again?"

Izuku's cock jumps back to life as he sees Katsuki sink his thumb back inside of him. "Ye-Yes. I could go all night if you keep this up."

"*Perfect*." Katsuki laughs. "Let's do the candy g-strings."



They burned through the edible underwear in twenty four hours. Izuku was sure some type of spell had come over them but he was happy to give into it. He partly considered that maybe Katsuki was an incubus, or *half* incubus at the very least. Because it felt like every time they had sex Katsuki's desire to have him grew stronger and stronger.

Later that evening, they laid side by side under the covers quietly.

They were cuddled, both turned inward and Izuku thought he could lay there forever. Katsuki's eyes were closed and he traced small hearts on Izuku's back.

"Are you going to read your book?" Katsuki asked, his voice was groggy with sleep. "You haven't touched it in a while."

Izuku hadn't even noticed, but Katsuki was right. He glanced over at the small night stand by his side of the bed. Laying there was his forgotten book slightly crooked on top of the wooden surface.

"You're right, I guess I'll read it a bit before bed," Izuku replied.

"M'kay," Katsuki muttered. He wrapped his arms around Izuku's waist. "Good night, darling."

"Goodnight, Kacchan."

Katsuki dozed off within a matter of seconds and Izuku smiled at the soft snoring. He grabbed his book on the night stand without rousing his husband and began to read a bit. He waited to be wrapped up in the magical spell it always held over him. His feet would suddenly feel like they were transported elsewhere and he could escape into the fantasy he adored so much.

However, he found himself not inclined to run away into his favorite world tonight.

He looked beside him at his husband.

He knew then he didn't need his fantasy world. The reality he wanted to experience was laying right beside him for the first time. He didn't need some eloquent sentence about the soul to tell him that this was because life with Katsuki was worth being present for.

This tiny sanctuary of happiness was a fantasy world of its own and Izuku didn't want to escape from it.

Chapter End Notes

Lemme know what you think below! Next chapter has the same new scenes, adding to the plot, and fluff between these too as they fall dangerously in love. Thanks so much for reading!

Chapter 25: Grazioso

Chapter Summary

Grazioso (style indicator) to play gracefully.

Chapter Notes

Hellooooo welcome back :)) This chapter is a big chunk of hurt and comfort with some fluff. I'm super excited for the next three chapters. Without further wait, hope you enjoy!!

Warnings: Adult Scenes and Themes

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 25 — Grazioso

.

.

.

Third Month of Honeymoon

The change of season snuck up on Izuku. He hadn't noticed when the leaves shifted from green to orange because he kept his eyes trained on Katsuki the whole time. When he bothered to finally pay attention to his surroundings, all of the trees were decorated in rich oranges, reds, and yellows.

He missed the change of seasons during their unlimited time together. So far it consisted of doing various things that were on Izuku's bucket list.

It made Izuku beam with light because little did Katsuki know, Izuku made that list as a bucket list to do with his future husband in his head. He thought it would be something private to keep in case one day he was fortunate enough to get married.

Now here they were, bound to one another and basking in married life.

They had a picnic. They did pottery. Izuku was even surprised when they baked together and made flower crowns. It was everything he could hope for as they did all the mundane things

Izuku wished to do in another lifetime.

Every event was full of domestic grace, even the one they were doing right now: spending time at a mall.

They were currently in a store that both Izuku and Katsuki loved. They decided they both really liked it after discovering this store stocked a lot of red and orange sweaters. It seemed like after Izuku gave Katsuki that one compliment, it was a green flag for him to buy more and more in that range of hues.

The amount of reds and oranges in Katsuki's closet *almost* rivaled his blacks now.

Izuku watched as Katsuki walked over to a clean, deep red suit and touched the fabric of it. He inspected the seams and assessed the durability with a small tug of his hands.

"What do you think of this?" Katsuki asked. "Most of my suits are black, and an orange suit would make me look like a goddamn clown, so how about red?"

Izuku hobbled over, and did the same thing Katsuki had done. He smiled up at his husband with a nod.

"I think you would look amazing in this, Kacchan," Izuku replied. "Where would you wear it though? It's kinda too high class for everyday wear."

Katsuki shrugged. "I dunno, anywhere fancy I guess. Maybe we can go to an orchestra one day and have the chance to dress up."

Izuku smiled at that thought. "Okay, I can't wait to see you in this suit!"

Katsuki took the suit off the hook and they continued to walk around. He kept a steady hand positioned at the small of Izuku's back to help steady him as he tried to walk with only one crutch. Overall, Izuku's ankle was getting better. It hurt less and Izuku was far more mobile now. There wasn't much left to heal, and truthfully he probably didn't need the crutch and cast anymore.

But Izuku didn't want to entirely admit that to himself. If he took the cast off, it was a signal that his time here was done.

As they wandered around the store, they came by the accessory section. Izuku looked at some of the sparkling jewelry and the glittering light of one bracelet caught his eye. They walked over to the section together, both of them focusing on different things.

Izuku picked up a tiny silver bracelet that he thought would probably make Katsuma ooh and aah. Dangling from it was a circular pendant and Izuku was pleasantly surprised to find it was a discreet locket. He smiled as he took it off the rack and held it up to the light.

Next to him Katsuki was surveying the leather belts. He glided his finger across several of them like he was considering an idea. Discreetly, he cut his eyes to Izuku and then unhooked one off the rack.

Katsuki gave his signature mischievous grin and held it up.

“You said you wanted to try something rougher in bed, right?” Katsuki asked with flirtation laced through his voice.

“Oh. Yeah—”

Izuku’s words died off the moment he came face to face with the belt.

A strange, unfamiliar feeling like prickling needles jabbed at his back. He suddenly became hesitant for reasons he was unsure of. But he glanced at Katsuki and bent under his need to please. He forced a tight lipped smile and nodded quickly.

“R-Right, I did!” Izuku said with an unsteady laugh. “Ho-How would we use a belt exactly? L-Like you would hit me with it?”

Katsuki looped the belt around his hand and Izuku grew stiffer by the second.

“Spank you with it,” Katsuki corrected and snapped the belt between his hands.

Izuku stilled his nerves when they jumped at the intense sound.

“Y’know how I sometimes spank your ass with my hand while we’re in the heat of the moment,” Katsuki continued. “You said you really liked the sting of that right?”

Izuku took a deep breath in and nodded with a sweet smile. “I-I do like it when you do that.”

“This will be kinda similar but more intense with a harsher sting. We can go over safety but I think you would enjoy it.”

Katsuki’s eyes were brimming with raw sexual excitement. This was clearly something he would be into, and Izuku knew it was something he *should* be into as well.

But he wasn’t so sure why he was feeling—*off* about the concept of a belt being used. A large part of him didn’t want to do this, but he told himself he didn’t want to disappoint Katsuki. He buried his own opinion and smiled.

“Okay, let’s do it,” Izuku said with forced confidence.

“Perfect. We can try a round tonight to see if you like it.”

Katsuki kissed the side of his head and they continued their shopping.

Izuku tried to be happy the rest of the time, but he found himself feigning a plastic, fake smile. A looming feeling close to dread was compiling at the base of his body and suddenly his arms were sore.

ɯɯɯ

They got home and Katsuki immediately set the mood.

They put away all the food and clothes they bought from their errands and Katsuki led him to their bedroom. Izuku nervously fidgeted on the comforter as Katsuki spread his legs for him and slotted between them.

Diving straight in, Katsuki gripped the base of Izuku's neck and tilted his head. The forceful action immediately surged heat straight down into Izuku's core and when Katsuki's lips connected with his skin, he lightly moaned. He spread his legs further when Katsuki's rough hand began to palm at his erection, moving in slow, generous circles.

"Right th-there," Izuku whispered breathlessly when Katsuki began to suck a hickey above his pulse.

He gripped Katsuki's hair and pushed his face in. Katsuki riled at the encouragement and began to rub Izuku's cock harsher through his jeans.

Izuku was all the way hard now, and the vulnerability of intimacy began to wash over him. He fluttered his eyes closed as the feeling encompassed him, surrendering to it fully.

He let himself be pushed backwards until his head hit the soft mattress, and Katsuki raked his hands up and down his sides. It tickled, and made him feel exposed. Izuku wiggled on the bed, waiting for more to happen, but nothing occurred right away.

Suddenly the warm hand on his neck disappeared, making him open his eyes again. He watched curiously when Katsuki snaked a hand down.

But when the hand returned, it was grasping the leather belt.

Izuku stiffened.

Visions of Tomura's face twisted in fury, anger, and repulsion flashed before his eyes.

Katsuki tenderly kissed his forehead and leaned up in order to loom over him. His husband easily wedged a knee between his legs, planting it directly against his erection. Izuku stifled a moan as he was stimulated while his body strangely seized up.

He tried to tell himself to enjoy the feeling but was unable to the longer he looked at the belt. It taunted him. As if it had eyes itself, he felt like it was glaring at him and telling him how weak he was. He tried to look away as Katsuki began to rock their bodies, but he *couldn't*.

Izuku's heart palpitated.

"With rougher play like this, it's extremely important to be communicative," Katsuki said. He smirked down at Izuku and pressed his knee into his crotch, rubbing it in slow circles under his shin. "You gotta be very vocal, okay? If it's too much, say 'red'. Got it?"

Izuku didn't nod or say yes. His eyes were trained on the belt in Katsuki's hand.

Katsuki frowned at the lack of response. "Izuku, did you hear me?"

Izuku couldn't talk. He tried to, but a lump in his throat was preventing him. His nostrils flared as he tried to stop himself from crying but it was useless. Out poured tears he didn't want, and visions of Tomura's face distorted by wrath suddenly replaced Katsuki's.

"Izuku?" Katsuki's voice sounded worried and far away. "Wh-What's wrong?"

Quickly, Katsuki glanced between Izuku and the belt. He moved it slightly and with it Izuku's eyes moved as well.

Katsuki cursed under his breath and hid the belt under the bed.

Once the object was gone, Izuku's breathing spiked with panic. Katsuki moved off of him and tried to shake him out of it, but found himself fruitless. Izuku screwed his eyes shut as his whole body shook and unwanted tears streamed down his face.

He meant to say something, but instead of words a loud, heartbreaking sob ripped from his lips. Izuku was horrified as more sobs tumbled out and he quickly lifted his hands to hide his face.

Katsuki was saying his name over and over again, with increasing urgency. But Izuku couldn't respond as he was transported across the worst parts of his memory.

It'd been five years since Tomura hit him with a belt, but somehow he still felt the welts on his skin as if they were cut into him yesterday. He heard every cruel thing Tomura said as he struck him over and over. Years of pain stacked on top of him and all Izuku could do was hide his face in shame.

Why was he crying?

Why couldn't he get it together?

Katsuki lifted him off the bed and secured his arms around him. He was trying his best to comfort Izuku as he quickly shuffled them further into the mattress. Izuku found himself unable to meet Katsuki's gaze. He failed him. They were supposed to be having *fun* but his defect got in the way.

Katsuki leaned his back against the headboard as he kept Izuku tightly secured. He wrapped his hands around Izuku and pressed Izuku's head against his chest to try to soothe him. He patted his hair and rocked back and forth with a terrified expression.

"It—It's okay, I'm sorry," Katsuki apologized with a splintering crack in his voice. It was clear he was unsure of what to do and Izuku felt like he screwed everything up. "I'm so fucking sorry, we don't have to do that, okay? Fuck it—f-forget it. It's done."

"I—" Izuku tried to speak but a wrenching sob overshadowed the words. "S-S-So—*Sorry*—"

"You have nothing to be sorry for," Katsuki corrected firmly. "I shouldn't have suggested that shit in the first place."

"B-But you wanted to," Izuku cried. "I-I ruined it."

“I don’t want to do anything that you don’t want to do, Izuku,” Katsuki whispered. He caressed Izuku’s hair more and pain crept into his words. “We never have to do that again.”

Izuku cried harder.

The vulnerability of the moment mixed with his searing memories. He tried to tell himself that it was fine, and he needed to snap out of this, but he found it impossible like climbing a flat wall. He dug his fingers into the bricks of his mental block but couldn’t scale it to find his way to the other side.

As Katsuki continued to ease him, Izuku felt disgusted with himself as a person and a viper. He didn’t deserve this type of treatment, and he couldn’t figure out why Katsuki always handled him with such care.



After what felt like an eternity, Izuku’s crying slowed up a bit. His eyes were sore every time he blinked and Katsuki hadn’t moved an inch. In fact, he rested his head against Izuku’s and kept his grip on him tight.

Izuku lifted his head, and was mortified to realize the sun had gone down. They were sitting in the dark by themselves. He inched his gaze up, horrified at what happened and he looked at Katsuki with deep remorse.

Katsuki was looking back at him, concerned beyond Izuku’s understanding.

When Izuku finally found his voice, he offered up the tiniest “sorry” he could manage.

Katsuki didn’t say anything.

Quietness filled the room and very carefully Katsuki rubbed his shoulders. His eyes darted all over Izuku’s face, body, and lingered on the faint scars that were on his arms. He seemed like he was about to be sick as he carefully wiped away Izuku’s tears with his palm.

“Was…Was it that Academy?” Katsuki whispered and his face twisted with fear.

Izuku seized up.

Years of violent silence training gagged his throat and told him to shut up. He felt the bluntness of Tomura’s hits and the gnawing pain of famine kick in his stomach. He stared into Katsuki’s eyes and was too frightened to move. But it seemed like his terrified silence said it all.

Katsuki carefully leaned in and chose his next words with care. “…Did that older brother of yours ever beat you with a belt?”

The question was pointed well enough that it was a yes or no. And no matter how much Izuku tried, he couldn’t lie to Katsuki. The wrongness of that felt like acid against his tongue and it started to overpower the resistance of talking about his upbringing.

Slowly, Izuku hung his head and nodded.

Katsuki gave a heartbroken sigh and hugged him. The simpleness from the warm touch made Izuku break down again. He tried to stifle his crying this time, and bit his lip to keep it in. But it poured out, slipping past the cracks in his armor.

“S-Sorry, th-this is so stupid,” Izuku said through his crying. He viciously wiped his tears away. “I feel so stupid, this never happened before—I-I don’t know wh-why I’m reacting like this—”

“It’s okay, Izuku,” Katsuki comforted.

“It’s not,” Izuku said. He shook his head as he buried his head in his hands. “It’s not okay, it’s *weak*. I’m sobbing over the sight of a belt. I’ve seen a thousand belts and—I-I’ve never reacted before—why now? Wh-Why am I being weak now?”

“—Hey,” Katsuki quipped. He frowned, grabbed Izuku’s hands, and pulled them down off his face. He made Izuku look him in the eye and Izuku quickly turned away. “It’s not weak. Don’t say that.”

“But it is weak,” Izuku whispered. “I’m weak and *defected* and this proves it. I shouldn’t be crying over something so *trivial* like this. I never cried over it before, I shouldn’t be crying about it now.”

Katsuki took a deep breath in and looked around the dark bedroom. He held onto Izuku’s wrists tighter and then shifted to interweaving their hands. Pain was pierced through all his handsome features and Izuku felt so bad for causing this much of a scene.

It was then Katsuki finally looked back towards him with genuine concern.

“Sometimes…” Katsuki whispered quietly. “Sometimes, when you are used to a certain type of treatment, you know it’s *bad*. But you don’t realize *how* bad it is until you’re away from it for a long time and you start to feel the change in your nervous system.”

Izuku furrowed his brow and slowly, his crying eased up. He looked at Katsuki’s raw, painful expression and his hands trembled.

“Th-That’s what happened with me and my mom when I moved out,” Katsuki confessed. “I always knew it was terrible while I was in it, but the second I moved out I realized just how *much* of it was wrong. Like I thought maybe fifty percent of her actions were horrible but when we separated, it went up to eighty. Things I accepted as regular every day occurrences, were actually *really* fuckin’ bad.”

Izuku listened carefully.

“After I moved out, I started feeling this hardened rock in my throat any time I was around her again,” Katsuki said, and his eyes grew glossy. “That never happened before, y’know? Then shortly after I started having visceral reactions to small things like the smell of rotten food. Even the idea of people paying their bills late pissed me off. I began to be so damn

irritable when any of my clothes gained a hole and I got this weird need to shower three times a day."

When explained this way, Izuku understood what Katsuki was getting at. He thought about everything Katsuki told him in comparison to what he was saying were triggers for him. Izuku knew triggers existed, but he didn't think about the fact that *he* could have them as an adult.

He was a viper after all—he wasn't supposed to be affected by such things.

"A reaction like this is normal when you've adjusted to…not being around who is hurting you," Katsuki concluded. He held on to Izuku's hands tighter. "Your body is trying to protect you from experiencing that pain again when you react to things associated with that person. It's warning you."

Izuku swallowed thickly.

His body was warning him against Tomura?

A long, uncomfortable stretch of silence passed. Izuku hung his head, lost in his thoughts while also too afraid to let go of Katsuki's hands. They sat there for a while before Katsuki pulled his attention again.

"Do…Do you want to talk about it?" Katsuki asked gently. "I try my best to not push you, and I want you to open up at your own speed about what you went through. But Izuku, this is *really* fucking serious. It would be good to confide in someone. To…confide in *me*. I *want* to be here for you."

Every lick of his upbringing was snapped into place at the thought of telling Katsuki *everything*.

He wanted to say yes and open up to Katsuki the same way Katsuki had done for him—but something deeply ingrained in him prevented that from happening. Like a swift hammer raining down on a nail, everything he wanted to say stayed pinned in place.

He glanced up from under his bangs. There, he saw the deflated way Katsuki's shoulders sagged at the lack of response.

It hurt him.

Izuku tried to find a sliver of confidence to speak about one thing. The most important thing he wanted to share with Katsuki.

"My…brother," Izuku said and pushed through the heaviness of his tongue. "His name is Tomura."

His heart was hammering and Katsuki perked up. He leaned in, listening intently.

"He…was in charge of me growing up," Izuku whispered. "If I messed up something, he would be the one to decide how I would be punished. Sometimes it would be quick punches

to the face, or slaps. Oftentimes he gave me the cold shoulder and refused to acknowledge me for days. But if I messed up badly by his standards, he usually chose the belt to punish me."

Izuku looked down at his shaking hands as it became difficult to speak.

"I would…" he whispered. "…I would have to kneel down with my shirt off and he would strike me on my head, shoulders, arms, and back over and over. My punishments were always…*hours*. And if I cried, he added on more time."

Katsuki's face twisted with mortification. His eyes went wide and he looked sick to his stomach.

"Izuku," Katsuki whispered his name like he was reading it on a grave. "You—You don't still go through that, do you?"

Izuku shook his head.

"But does he still hurt you in other ways?" Katsuki pressed on.

Izuku grew stiff and lost his ability to speak once more. His eyes darted all around when he realized how deeply their upbringing drilled obedience inside of them. But he didn't want to hurt Katsuki by shutting him out.

He nodded the best he could as an answer.

Katsuki worked his jaw. His eyes were caught between horror, fear, and anger. The three emotions mixed like a dangerous concoction ready to explode and Katsuki seemed like he was about to boil over any minute now.

Izuku felt so ashamed for the drama he caused, and he wanted to continue telling Katsuki how sorry he was. But before he could, Katsuki pulled him into another embrace.

This one was full of protectiveness, and Izuku closed his eyes to let himself be held as he came down from his stressful state.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Somewhere along the line, Izuku fell asleep. All he remembered was crying and feeling like Katsuki's arms were the only safety shield he had against reality.

When he woke up, it was the dead of night. He turned to see Katsuki was not in bed with him, instead he was crouched down at the bottom of the closet. Izuku squinted in the dark room and was able to make out Katsuki holding a small, cardboard box. With a level of anger, Katsuki was huffing and dumping something inside at rapid speed.

Izuku craned his neck and his eyes widened when he saw what was sitting inside the box.

Belts.

Izuku pressed his lips in a thin line. "You don't have to do that, Kacchan."

Katsuki paused and peered over his shoulder to Izuku. His eyes were an agitated red and his brows were pulled down displaying how pissed off he was.

“It’s fine,” Katsuki replied curtly, leaving no room for argument. “Don’t worry about it. Go back to sleep.”

Katsuki wordlessly put the last belt in the box and tightly packaged it up. He lifted himself up from his crouched position and gave Izuku a stern stare. Izuku wanted to protest, but the sharpness of Katsuki’s eyes were burning with resolve and he knew there would be no arguing.

Katsuki walked out of the room with the box to somewhere unknown.

Izuku never saw another belt in the house after that.



When the morning came, Izuku felt like he was wearing a cloak of shame.

He hadn’t meant for his emotions to cause such a dramatic scene. It made him feel oddly bare, being laid out like that and having such a strong defect highlighted. He felt weak. He felt vulnerable. And he hated feeling like either of those things. All his life, he worked hard to go against his emotions in order to protect himself. Because every time they slipped through, something bad happened—and the outcome was never good.

And Izuku didn’t want Katsuki to feel burdened in the same way Tomura always was.

They didn’t speak much, and Izuku could practically see gears turning in Katsuki’s head. His husband was always a man of little words, but he made up for it in the confidence of his actions.

Izuku silently sat at the kitchen table as Katsuki prepped breakfast. When he put the plate in front of Izuku, Izuku couldn’t help but crack a small smile. It was his favorite breakfast dishes: Tamagoyaki, pickled cabbage, and grilled salmon.

Katsuki sat down and poured a cup of coffee for them both.

After they finished eating, Katsuki finally spoke up.

“You know we have to talk about what happened last night, right?” Katsuki said firmly. “I don’t believe in avoiding serious shit like that.”

Izuku licked his lips. Of course, Katsuki faced everything head on in life. He was always the chaser while Izuku was the runner.

“Ri-Right.” Izuku sucked in a deep breath and bowed his head. “Um. I’m really sorry about breaking down like that. It won’t happen again.”

Katsuki scoffed immediately and shook his head. “That’s not what I meant at all. Were you feeling uncomfortable about the belt from the start, like from the second I proposed the idea?”

“I was,” Izuku admitted honestly and averted his eyes. “But you seemed so excited to try. I figured it…it would be something worth doing if it was what you wanted to do.”

“But what about what *you* wanted? Why didn’t you speak up sooner?”

“I—I didn’t consider that as an option. I don’t usually…have a choice in saying no to things so speaking up doesn’t come naturally to me.”

Katsuki frowned so deeply he probably gained a new facial wrinkle.

A trickle of silence found its way between them as Katsuki probed his tongue into his cheek.

Truthfully, Izuku hadn’t considered saying ‘no’ to anything in a long time. The very few times he voiced what he didn’t want, he was promptly run over. He found himself deeply hurt, or in a fist fight with Tomura, whenever he voiced his opinions, so he stopped being so opinionated. It was always easier to go with whatever was being asked of him.

“Izuku,” Katsuki whispered. He reached for his hand with a weary expression. “If there’s anything that makes you uncomfortable even in the fuckin’ *slightest*, you can speak up and tell me, okay? I won’t get mad. I won’t even be disappointed or frustrated.”

The concept was new.

Izuku stared at Katsuki waiting for the gotcha moment. There was always a fine print when it came to men, especially the powerful ones. However, several beats of silence passed and there was no catch.

“Your opinion matters to me,” Katsuki whispered. He caressed the top of Izuku’s hand and his expression melted to gentleness. “It matters a whole lot to me. As long as you’re around me, anything you want, we can do. And shit that you don’t want, we don’t have to. Okay?”

Izuku’s heart was directly hit and he unwillingly shed tears. Katsuki held his hand tighter and scooted in closer to wipe the onslaught of sadness away.

As he silently cried, Izuku had no clue he was holding so much in.

It felt like he was truly living in a fantasy at that thought. Between Tomura and his viper family, there was no room for his wants or needs. He’d only been able to harness his new found bravery in the name of Katsuma and the other kids back home.

Izuku realized then if the new cohort never came along, he might not have ever defied Tomura. He wouldn’t have bravely asked for the Okinawa mission, and he wouldn’t have found the courage to ask Aoyama to tamper with his tracker. Izuku would have never reconnected with Kacchan because he would have never thought to take a stand for himself.

He always acted for the sake of others.

He looked at Katsuki and found himself inspired slightly. Katsuki was always brave, and he frequently put himself first in the grand scheme of things. He voiced what he wanted and barely backed down when he felt like he was in the right. Izuku thought Katsuki basked in a light of bravery that he always admired, and maybe, just maybe, Izuku could learn to bask in it too.

“Okay,” Izuku whispered, hands shaking at the thought. “B-But it might take me a minute to get used to voicing my opinions. I haven’t done much for myself. Being with you was the first choice I really ever made that would be considered slightly selfish.”

Katsuki beamed at Izuku’s willingness to try. He leaned in closely and offered up his signature lopsided smile. Izuku couldn’t help but return the gesture and he felt Katsuki begin to rub off on him.

“We can practice,” Katsuki reassured. “It’ll take time like you said, but we can start small and work our way up until you feel comfortable being more vocal about your wants and needs.”

“How would we start practicing?”

“Tell me something you don’t want. Right now. We can start small.”

This was a decent level of ridiculous. But Izuku wanted to follow Katsuki’s lead and learn how to grasp life by the wheels. He looked around the kitchen and found himself staring at the dark liquid in the mug on the table.

“I…I don’t want coffee,” Izuku confessed in a small voice. “I don’t like it.”

“Really?” Katsuki said, surprised.

“Y-Yeah. I only drank it because I was told caffeine will help keep me focused for missions. A-And you seemed to like it a lot once we got here so I kept drinking it whenever you offered it to me. But I prefer tea.”

Katsuki nodded with a grin and slid the cup of coffee away from Izuku. “You got it. You never have to drink a drop of coffee as long as I’m around.”

It was such a small thing, but Izuku was relieved. He smiled at his husband and his heart began to hammer out of control.

“Anything else you don’t want?” Katsuki asked.

“I—” Izuku licked his lips as he stared at Katsuki. He pondered a thought he was unsure he should follow, but the warmth of Katsuki’s hand guided him to speak what was on his mind. “I-I don’t want you to look at me differently because of this.”

Katsuki shook his head. “Of course I wouldn’t.”

“Then can we go back to the bedroom and…” He bit his lip and gave a shy squeeze of the hands. “I still want to, just not with a belt.”

Katsuki's face lit up and he nodded. He smoothly shifted into his bedroom eyes and leaned in to carefully lift Izuku's chin for a kiss.

"Of course," Katsuki whispered. "No extra shit today."

The moment they locked lips, Izuku sighed into the kiss and found himself overcome with shaky relief. Katsuki's tongue swiped at his bottom lip, asking for permission and Izuku gave it. Ounces of passion seeped through their skin and tethered them together in a delicate interwinding. Katsuki deepened the kiss, and Izuku immediately wrapped his arms around his husband's neck.

It took two seconds for Katsuki to gather Izuku in his arms and hoist him up.

They broke apart and both smiled as Katsuki began to walk them back to their bedroom.

Izuku blushed happily as he was laid down on their bed and Katsuki joined him. They both began to strip themselves naked and Izuku was overjoyed how nothing really changed. A simple boundary was set and he was content to know they would never have to cross that bridge again. As Izuku threw away the last of his clothing, he eagerly watched as Katsuki did the same.

Once they were both nude, their bodies melted against one another and Izuku enjoyed the familiar warmth it brought him. Instantly, a tantalizing rush took hold of him as Katsuki reached down and grabbed his erection. He moaned softly as Katsuki pumped him with one hand and reached for the half empty bottle of lube with the other.

Pleasure raked across his body as Katsuki's hand engulfed his half hardened cock and twisted at the tip. He spread his legs automatically at the sound of the tube uncapping. Katsuki squeezed it over him, and Izuku relished the tingle of the slickness dripping down on to his sensitive length. The erotic sensation spread in a chain reaction as it rolled up from his belly to his head.

Izuku searched for Katsuki's cock, and when he found it he began to stroke it in sync with how his husband was pleasuring him. Katsuki groaned and lathered a generous amount of lube all over his thick erection as well. They both pumped each other as they laid on the bed, staring into each other's eyes.

Izuku felt his toes curl as the pleasure began to build. He bit his lip as the intensity of Katsuki's gaze and stroking grew more passionate with every passing second. With a particular flick of the wrist, Katsuki made him twitch with intense arousal. Izuku shuddered on the bed as he arched his back and his mouth dropped open.

"What do you want?" Katsuki asked like he was starving. "Do you want to cum like this?"

"No." Izuku moaned and shook his head. "I-I want to cum with you inside of me."

Katsuki nodded eagerly. He quickly retreated his hand and a shaky breath slipped past Izuku's lips. Warm fingers slipped down Izuku's body to find their way at his backside. They probed politely and Izuku easily spread his legs as beads of sweat began to gather at his

hairline. His hand that was gripped around his husband's cock switched to slow, sensual strokes as Katsuki rubbed two fingers to wet his entrance.

Katsuki pushed in easily. Izuku's hole was well used from the last three months, forming around Katsuki's fingers like they were meant to be there. This made Katsuki wickedly grin at how smoothly he was able to penetrate Izuku and dove straight for his prostate, pulling out a gasp.

"Your body is so well adjusted to me now," Katsuki complimented with a hint of hunger. He rubbed down on Izuku's sweet spot and kissed his forehead when Izuku gave a full body shudder. "This little hole of yours is a perfect fit now."

Izuku moaned loudly as his husband fucked his fingers in and out. His eyes fluttered closed as he was slowly teased and pushed into a drowning sea of rapture. With every push, ripples of pleasure charged through him. His nipples perked to life and all the nerve endings in his body jumped with euphoric electricity. Izuku's chest began to rise and fall like the growing tides as Katsuki fingered him at his leisure.

When Izuku opened his eyes again, Katsuki was staring at him, drinking in his erotic facial expressions.

The look in those eyes made Izuku surge forward and capture Katsuki's lips for a kiss. The sweetest of Katsuki's tongue brushed against his, making Izuku whine into their joined mouths.

They kept kissing, desperate for the other as Katsuki eased his wet fingers out. Izuku wrapped his arms around Katsuki at the same time Katsuki wrapped his arms around him. They broke apart and Izuku dragged his lips across Katsuki's jaw, nipping at his skin along the way.

As he worked, sucking and sinking his greedy teeth into his husband's neck, Katsuki flipped Izuku's body on top of his and made him straddle him.

Izuku froze and realized the position they were in was one they hadn't tried yet.

He pulled back and looked down at his husband who was underneath him. Absolute mischief was dancing in Katsuki's beautiful eyes as he flirtatiously wiggled his eyebrows. Izuku slid back a bit as he sat up, and Katsuki's thick cock slotted between his cheeks.

Izuku bit his lip as he looked down at Katsuki.

"I got you," Katsuki encouraged. "Pleasure yourself at your own pace."

Izuku blushed as he looked down at his husband's chest. From this angle he had the perfect view of Katsuki's earnings from his intensive workouts. Sweat was making his skin glisten as his silver chain stuck to his collarbone. It riled Izuku up a bit, seeing his husband laid out like this. But more so, he loved the feeling of Katsuki's hands planted directly on his waist, helping keep him steady.

Izuku splayed his shaky hands across Katsuki's chest, one on each pec and he slowly lifted his body the best he could with his cast. Katsuki helped him, lifting him high enough to press his wet tip against Izuku's backside.

Izuku bit his lip as he was lowered down gingerly. The slickness of his husband's cock stretched him all the way open and Izuku's breath hitched higher and higher with each inch that sank into him.

They both softly groaned when Katsuki was successfully inside.

Izuku steadied his breathing as he experimentally rolled his hips. It was a low grind, and it didn't quite hit his sweet spot right away the way Katsuki always knew how. Izuku shyly looked down at Katsuki who was watching him as if this was something straight out of his wildest dreams.

"Take it easy," Katsuki whispered. He lovingly drew hearts along Izuku's hip bone and slowly nodded. "There's no rush."

Izuku slowly nodded as well. His chest filled up with a warm sensation as he began to test out the feeling of riding Katsuki. He worked at various combinations of different speeds and angles. He felt embarrassed as he rocked his hips in all sorts of ways, and each time he found something almost right, Katsuki praised him.

It was a strange feeling being in control of the pace like this, but Izuku found he liked it. He gained another wave of courage and slowly lifted himself up high and then slid back down.

The throaty groan he elicited from Katsuki was down right erotic.

Izuku wanted more of it so he did the same motion again. As a reward, he got the same reaction. Egged on by Katsuki's raspy voice, Izuku began to bounce lightly, fucking himself on his husband's cock. He slowly found the rhythm that worked and Katsuki smirked up at him with full lust blown eyes.

"There you go," Katsuki groaned, hitting the lowest part of his vocal cords.

Izuku's heart swelled at the validation and he tried to go faster. In the process he angled himself by accident—and when he landed down, Izuku cried out loud as the tip of Katsuki's length struck directly against his prostate.

Izuku's breathing staggered at how good it felt in this position. He angled himself just right and he did it again, and again, and again until he was greedily bouncing up and down on Katsuki. Katsuki's groans mixed with Izuku's moans as they found their rhythm and bliss took over both their faces.

Izuku's head of curls beautifully moved with his motions as he rode Katsuki eagerly. It felt so *good* Izuku hadn't a clue that they were missing out on this. Every impale was punctuated with an addictive wave of pleasure as Izuku struck that spot inside of him over and over. He wanted more and lost himself to controlling his own pleasure.

“*Darling*,” Katsuki moaned and Izuku tingled at the pet name. “You look downright *sinful* from this view.”

Izuku shivered at the praise and his body tightened. Katsuki’s toes curled at the action and he bit his lip seductively.

“You like it when I praise you, huh?” Katsuki asked through his panting.

“Ye-Yeah.” Izuku nodded bashfully, and ground down.

“God you feel so tight, darling,” Katsuki drawled out. Izuku’s breath hitched at the words. “You’re so *so* amazing at riding my cock.”

Izuku rocked his hips faster as the words slid down his body like viscous honey.

“You’re going to make me cum like this,” Katsuki continued to praise. “Keep going. Pleasure yourself on me the way you want it. I’m loving this so damn much.”

The large hands on his hips were sinking in so deeply helping Izuku fuck himself senseless and Izuku never felt so wonderfully in control of his body before. He cried out loudly as he reached new highs and below him Katsuki stared up at him like he was witnessing something beautiful.

“Whose cock is it, darling?” Katsuki asked through his groans.

“Y-Yours, Kacchan!”

Katsuki shook his head and slammed his hips upwards, shocking Izuku with the force. He ground upwards into Izuku and the sensation filled Izuku’s body with so much crazed pleasure he rolled his eyes back.

“*Wrong*,” Katsuki corrected through a fierce hiss.

He thrusted into Izuku again, drawing out a beautiful moan. He took one of Izuku’s hands and guided him to touch where their bodies were joined. Izuku bit his lip at the wetness and how far stretched he was.

“This cock buried inside of you right here, is *yours*.”

Izuku furrowed his brow. “Mine?”

Katsuki rocked their bodies, and they both gently moaned. “Yes. *Yours*. Try saying it.”

“It-It’s mine,” Izuku moaned as he presumed to bounce again. He struck his pleasure button and his toes curled at the thought. “This cock is *mine*.”

Katsuki smirked and nodded. He bit his lip as Izuku picked up speed again and began to fill their bodies with tantalizing ripples of pleasure. The sound of slapping flesh echoed throughout their bedroom as Katsuki held on tightly to his husband who was losing himself to the feeling.

“Exactly,” Katsuki agreed. He took Izuku’s hand, guided it to touch himself, and groaned at the way Izuku immediately began to stroke his own length. “This cock is yours. And you know what you can do when *your* husband’s cock is fucking this sweet ass of yours?” He began to meet Izuku’s rhythm, doubling their euphoria and Izuku’s core tightened with heat. “You can tell me to go faster, slower, *harder*—anything your beautiful ass wants.”

They held deep, burning eye contact as Katsuki said this and it lit everything in Izuku on fire. He moaned loudly and fucked himself with fever on the thick length. The tantalizing excitement echoed through his limbs and Izuku wanted more so badly.

Izuku screwed his eyes shut and shyly commanded, “F-fuck me harder.”

Katsuki began to fuck him harder.

“D-Deeper!” Izuku instructed and Katsuki did just that.

Izuku was vehemently rocked on top of Katsuki and his eyes were nearly crossing as he was over stimulated. One large, powerful thrust moved his whole body. He gasped as his free hand lost balance and shot forward for purchase. He grabbed Katsuki’s silver chain and tugged it by accident but decided he liked the feeling. He tugged it again, and found it made Katsuki rock deeper. So he did it again and again and again.

Katsuki groaned as Izuku stayed in control of his chain as he rode him without shame.

From his fingers to his toes, Izuku was radiating searing heat all over as his prostate was milked. He stroked his cock faster as he bounced vigorously, climbing to his peak. His moans built on top of each other as he squeezed the base of his cock at the same time he tightened his hole around Katsuki. He felt himself nearing his orgasm and looked down at his husband.

Izuku brazenly tugged Katsuki’s chain. “Open your mouth.”

Katsuki did exactly that while holding eye contact and the sight sent Izuku over the edge.

His orgasm hit him like a tsunami and drowned him down in pleasure. He impaled himself one last, powerful time and it pushed out a loud moan from the back of his throat. Izuku screwed his eyes shut as he arched his back and came. His cock pulsed and ribbons of cum shot out to spray across Katsuki’s chiseled chest, chin, and some of it landed directly in his mouth.

Katsuki fiendishly grinned and swallowed Izuku’s cum. He shot his tongue out to lick up the warm liquid that landed on his lips. He buried himself deep, and unleashed his own cum into Izuku’s tight, welcoming body. Katsuki closed his eyes in beautiful rapture as his orgasm pulled through his bones.

Izuku watched, soaking in every detail. He knew there would be bruises on his hips tomorrow, and he eagerly wanted more. The seeping warmness of Katsuki’s cum filled him slowly, like a rising sun. He loved it, and he adored how it made him feel so full and appreciated.

Izuku limped forward and he put his head on top of Katsuki's chest. They both breathed heavily as Katsuki wrapped his arms around him. The cock inside of him slipped out with a slick pop and they both laughed lightly.

"Did you like that?" Katsuki asked, entirely out of breath.

Izuku nodded tiredly. "I did. I *really* liked that."

"Perfect. What do you want to do next, darling?" Katsuki kissed the top of his head. "I know you still have a couple rounds in you."

Izuku leaned back and gazed down at his husband lustfully.

"Can we do doggy next? I-I really like when we do that and you do, y'know, smack my backside hard." Izuku whispered the last part.

Katsuki laughed lightly. "We *absolutely* can do that."

Katsuki leaned in and gave him a quick kiss on the lips and placed a hand on his thigh. By accident, his fingers brushed against the sensitive area of Izuku's inner leg and Izuku giggled. Katsuki grinned at the lighthearted action and brushed his finger against the spot again, and Izuku let out another stifled chuckle.

"All playfulness aside, do you like it when I touch you here?" Katsuki asked carefully.

Izuku nodded happily. "I do."

"Okay." Katsuki kissed him again. "Just double checking. Still can't get over how you have such a sensitive spot on your already sensitive body. So damn cute."

Izuku laughed as Katsuki continued to toy with that part of his thigh. They melted into each other easily and Izuku appreciated how safe he felt.

"Thank you, Kacchan," Izuku said earnestly. "For everything. Thank you for listening and helping me to try to feel confident."

"You don't have to thank me," Katsuki replied. "If we have to go our separate ways after this, I want you to leave with feeling like what you feel and say matters. Because it does."

It didn't slip by Izuku how Katsuki used the word 'if'. It hung in the air the same way 'forever' did and they both assessed the other one carefully. He hadn't outright said it, but Izuku knew Katsuki was carefully tempting him into staying. He had successfully tempted him into several things now, and this would be the final nail in the coffin.

As Izuku thought about everything that transpired the last twenty four hours, Izuku was considering staying now. Heavily.

Maybe after he got the kids out, he could actually find a life of grace with Katsuki.

ɯɯɯ

The rest of the day consisted of doing things Izuku wanted to do and Katsuki happily obliged.

There even was a ridiculous part where Katsuki made him sit down and practice saying ‘no’ in various forms. Some of Katsuki’s favorite ways to say no were “fuck off” and “kiss my pale ass” but Izuku wasn’t sure he would take that approach *quite* yet. He settled for the more polite ways to get his point across.

By the time the night sky was full of stars, Izuku felt slightly more reassured in how to be more straightforward. Katsuki told him it was okay to be selfish, and if he felt like something was right he should blaze forward with all his might. He shouldn’t compromise and never allow himself to be shrunken down for the sake of others who want to dim his light.

It was all good advice, and Izuku felt confident in what he wanted now. Because after today, the *one* thing he wanted for himself was to find a way to keep Katsuki in his life.

He didn’t want to part ways.

Katsuki gave him his courage today, but he also gave him something else.

Izuku probed the sensitive area on his leg. Tingles raced down to his toes.

Izuku peaked over to make sure Katsuki was fast asleep. His husband was sprawled out on the bed, frowning in his dreams. The second Izuku saw the forehead crease between Katsuki’s eyes set in place, he knew Katsuki wouldn’t wake up unless shaken.

Izuku quietly rose up, and limped himself to his duffle bag. He pulled out his fang shaped blade, and the tiny locket he purchased for Katsuma then limped towards the bathroom.

Once inside, he locked the door and sat down on the closed lid of the toilet. He wriggled out of his pajama pants to expose his inner thigh. He touched it exactly like Katsuki has done so many times already. He sucked in a deep breath when his skin tickled.

Izuku pressed his fingers in deeper and held back from laughing out of joy and frustration.

Katsuki pinpointed his tracker.

Izuku thought about what Katsuki said about taking control. Somehow down the line, Katsuki pointed him directly to the path that he needed to truly do exactly that.

He leaned over to the sink and opened the bottom drawer. With shaky hands, Izuku gripped the first-aid kit and popped it open. He placed down the locket and took the bandaging out. He wrapped it around his upper thigh and tied the knot solidly until he felt his blood flow cut off.

He set down a towel underneath him and neatly placed out everything he needed. Needle. Vinyl stitches. Antiseptic. He took off one of his socks and placed it in his mouth as a gag.

Izuku held up his blade and unsheathed it slowly.

He swallowed in anticipation at what he was about to do. He closed his eyes and waited until he felt a numbness in his leg. As he did this, he imagined a life with Katsuki still in it. Beautiful red eyes and blond hair would still be a part of his wretched existence after everything was said and done if he played this correctly.

Without the tracker directly in his body, he could leave it somewhere and freely move about.

Even better, he could easily slip past viper security and no one would be able to tell he was delivering the kids back to their parents if he could manipulate the location of his signal. He could warn the families ahead of time to get far away and potentially change their names. He could then slide back to the academy like he had no idea what happened and maybe even visit Katsuki on weekends.

As defiance pulsed through Izuku's veins, the ghost of Hiryu appeared for the first time in months. Izuku nearly forgot about his haunting, and the shadow of his dead brother lurked in the corner curiously, watching him with those blackened eyes.

"Tomura was wrong when he said you were his mini me," Hiryu's ghost quipped. "It looks like you're mine."

Izuku hesitated slightly, remembering how Hiryu's fate ended. But then he shook it off as he thought about both Katsuma and Katsuki. He wanted a better life for not only Katsuma now, but himself too. He tested the numbness of his leg and it felt like pricking needles.

Perfect.

He bit down hard on the sock in his mouth and he fought against all his instincts. With one hand he gripped the area of flesh and with the other he pressed the tip of his blade to the center of the sensitive spot.

With every inch of courage he possessed, Izuku sunk it in.

He cried in pain into the sock as his mouth watered in agony. He dug the blade slowly into himself and blood dripped down onto the towel on the floor like a slow metronome.

Izuku screwed his eyes shut and pushed through with the help of imagining a future with Katsuki. He saw his husband's lopsided smirk and how he would gently call him 'darling'. He saw them dancing together and playing violin music. He felt the loving caress of Katsuki's hands against his skin and heard his voice encourage him.

When the tip of his blade connected with something metal Izuku's heart stopped.

He pulled out the blade, and grappled quickly for the tweezers. He dug them in surgically, hissing at the terrible feeling of being pried open. He slowly poked for the tracker, and when he found it, ripples of pain shot across his nerves. Izuku's breathing drew close to hyperventilating when he gave a brutal tug.

Out came the tiny chip covered in blood.

Izuku held it up to his eyes and slowly began to laugh through his tears.

How *small* was the thing that stole both his and Hiryu's freedom.

Izuku trembled as he placed down the tracker onto the towel below. He carefully tended to his wound and wiped it clean. He hissed at the horrible sting of antiseptic and gritted through the pain of self inserted sutures. He cut the thread and bandaged up his wound with tender care.

After he cleaned up the scene he locked the tracker into the tiny locket.

Izuku's chest was pounding. His vision slightly swayed as he held up the bracelet to the light. It shone like it was freedom embodied, capturing the tempting glitter of free will that it promised. Izuku smiled half way as he thought about a future that allowed him more wiggle room.

Off on the corner, Hiryu's spirit lightened up. His forgotten brother smiled at him, and disappeared.

Izuku did it. He removed his tracker in tack.

ᔓᔓᔓ

The next day Izuku stashed the locket in his bag. He buried it deep so there was no room for it to be tampered with.

When Katsuki eventually noticed the bloodied bandage around his leg, he was rightfully alarmed. Izuku wrote off his injury to him slipping and falling in the kitchen by accident in the middle of the night. He explained that he'd been trying to chop up some leftovers, and his knee gave out suddenly and made him topple over.

Katsuki was mortified. He fawned over Izuku like he nearly died and tried to inspect the wound, but Izuku brushed him off. Izuku quietly deflected and told him he would be okay, and he didn't want Katsuki to worry about something as small as a cut.

Katsuki seemed to only half believe this, but he didn't want to push Izuku it seemed like.

Over the next week, Katsuki was gracefully kind with him. Izuku found himself feeling more emboldened as the days went by. He was happy a trait of Katsuki was rubbing off on him in what he felt like was a positive manner.

It was now a sunny, fall day. He was patiently sitting in the kitchen as he waited for Katsuki. He'd been told to sit still and wait for his husband to join him—but he was taking forever.

"Kacchan?" Izuku called out impatiently when he heard some rustling. "What are you doing back there?"

"Just sit tight will ya," Katsuki grumbled. "I'll be out in a minute!"

Izuku sighed and shook his head. Katsuki was acting weird all day. First, he left the estate without telling Izuku and next he came back and acted like Izuku couldn't see what was

inside the bags and boxes. He supposed this is what he got for being secretive about his injury.

Then suddenly Katsuki rounded the corner.

Izuku's eyes went wide.

His husband walked into the kitchen extremely slowly, balancing a cake in his hands.

"Happy birthday, you fucking nerd," Katsuki announced with a lopsided smirk.

Izuku's jaw dropped.

Staring back at him was a three-tier vanilla cake with strawberries and chocolate drizzled along the sides. The various layers had different types of cookie crumbles spread across the tops and the sweet smell wafting off of it watered Izuku's mouth.

Katsuki carefully placed it down on the table and Izuku's heart stopped at the words 'Happy birthday, Izuku!' that was written across it in icing.

"B-Birthday?" Izuku parroted. His nose scrunched and his hands curled into himself wondering if Katsuki forgot exactly when his birthday was. "Kacchan, it's November. My birthday is in July."

Katsuki chuckled and ignored the comment. Then he quickly reached behind him and exposed the bright green sash that read 'Happy Birth!' in big, white lettering.

"Yeah, yeah, I know when your damn birthday is," Katsuki quipped. "In case you forgot, we have celebrated it before, and I have a decent memory sometimes." He pulled the sash over Izuku's head, and Izuku couldn't believe what was happening. "Now we get to have a second celebration together."

Izuku's eyes repeatedly darted between Katsuki, the cake, and the sash.

"B-But why?" Izuku questioned, unsure. His heart began to clutch because Katsuki's kindness kept compiling. "I don't really understand why you're—wh-why you're doing all of this suddenly."

"Because on your bucket list you wrote 'have a birthday party'," Katsuki reminded him. He took out a single candle from his pocket and a lighter. He lifted up the two items before sticking the candle on top of the cake. "I know it's not the right day, but I figured this is the least I can do to make up for Tokyo. It was the last thing on your bucket list. We officially completed it."

Katsuki lit the candle.

Tears welled up in Izuku's eyes. They completed the list of everything he wanted to do as a married couple. Somehow, Katsuki made sure to give Izuku everything he wanted, and taught him how to speak up for himself in the process.

Katsuki turned to Izuku, and his grin was wiped off his face.

“What are you crying for?” Katsuki asked as gently as he could. He sat down quickly and looked at Izuku. “Is this too much?”

“Sorry,” Izuku sobbed slightly, he didn’t even realize he began to cry. He pressed his palms into his eyes and shook his head. “I-I’m sorry I didn’t mean to cry. I-I love everything.” Izuku removed his hands and stared at Katsuki once more. Emotion overcame him as he saw everything he ever wanted laying in front of him. “You got the cake I like, the sash, a-and—” Izuku hiccuped lightly. He wiped away more tears furiously. “You got me everything I-I put on my dumb list.”

Katsuki grabbed Izuku’s hands. “Of course I did. Now, blow out your candle and make a wish—that is, if you have one. Do you have something to wish for this time around?” Katsuki asked.

Izuku’s smile was fragile, threatening to fall and shatter. “I do have a wish this time.”

Izuku turned to the candle and he watched the flame dance under his gaze. He smiled as he saw the one person he wanted most in the world smile back at him. Izuku closed his eyes and made his wish.

I wish to stay this happy and remain with Kacchan the rest of my life.

Izuku breathed in and blew out the candle full of hope.

Katsuki smiled, clapped lightly, and cheered. He gave deep howls like he was Izuku’s biggest fan and successfully made Izuku laugh with a blush. They cut the cake together, and Katsuki made sure to give Izuku the biggest piece he could possibly eat in one sitting. Katsuki hurried to play upbeat music in the background and two tiny birds chirped from the windowsill.

As they laughed and ate cake, Katsuki perked up with a large smile.

“Hold still, I’ll be right back,” Katsuki quickly said.

He ran into their bedroom and returned with a giant box that was wrapped in royal blue paper. There was a large red bow on the top and Izuku’s heart leaped out of his chest at the sight of a small tag that read ‘For: Bakugou Izuku.’

Izuku clasped his hands together and teamed with excitement.

Katsuki handed the box to Izuku, and said, “For my darling husband.”

Izuku smiled happily and ripped open the box. When he dug his fingers into the wrapping paper he gasped in surprise at the sight of one of his favorite things.

“Books?” Izuku exclaimed happily. He held up one and immediately blushed at the sight of the cover. “Oh! *Romance* books!”

“Yup. By the same author of that really old one you carry around,” Katsuki pointed out. He proudly leaned back as Izuku’s eyes sparked to life. “Turns out they have a lot of new series out. I figured you’ve been too busy to ever look into their newer stories, but I got you all the recent ones so you can have a big ol’ nerdy field day.”

Izuku smiled until his cheeks hurt.

“This is exactly what I wanted,” Izuku said honestly. “Thank you so much, Kacchan. Ah, I can’t wait to read these. I-Is it okay if I look through a couple of them now? Just too skim!”

“Go crazy, darling,” Katsuki encouraged.

Izuku squealed slightly and began thumbing through all the fresh pages.

As he did this, Izuku couldn’t contain his excitement. He started looking at the dictation and found that the author changed the way they used similes and Izuku was so stoked to read how much they’d grown as a writer.

Katsuki watched him and tilted his head.

“What about these plots do you like so much?” Katsuki asked innocently.

Izuku bashfully scratched his cheek. “Ah, it’s a bit much to explain, there’s a lot going on.”

“Explain away. I’m all ears.”

So Izuku did. He happily started talking about the plot to his lover and found Katsuki was hanging on his every word. The intense way Katsuki was listening to him was something Izuku never experienced before. Usually he kept to himself about his interests, shamed at how much he loved the things that brought him joy. But of course, Katsuki made him feel safe enough to be himself fully.

Katsuki propped his chin on his fist as he leaned in closely.

Izuku’s heart fluttered at the sight. When he was about half way done explaining the plot of the two star crossed lovers, Katsuki sat up straight and cleared his throat.

“Izuku,” Katsuki interrupted. “In your romance books, how did the characters know they were in love?”

“Ah, it happens gradually,” Izuku answered easily. He drew invisible circles on the table as he smiled happily. For once he was able to share his hobby without ridicule. “There’s never a moment where the character declares they start loving the other person. They slowly start to realize little things or cues as they fall progressively in love.”

“Tell me. What are the cues?”

“How come?” Izuku questioned innocently. “Are you interested in the books now too?”

“Something like that,” Katsuki said. He leaned in close to Izuku and gave him his full attention. “Maybe I was wrong about romance being bullshit and all. The bit of the book I did read was really great and we had a lot of fun afterward, hm? Maybe I need to be more open minded.”

Izuku grinned wide, and his eyes filled with admiration.

He and Katsuki were really fated, weren’t they? He was teaching Katsuki how to be romantic and Katsuki was teaching him how to be brave. They fit together so well, and Izuku could only imagine what more they could learn from each other in the future.

Their future.

His heart simmered with the affection he carried for Katsuki, and he soon was explaining how he knew he was in love. Not anything to do with his books.

“Well, usually the first sign is their heart speeds up around the other person,” Izuku said tenderly as he thought about the way he always felt his ribcage rattle at the sight of Katsuki. “Then they look at the person in a new light. Almost like viewing them for the first time and how they can fit in their life in ways they didn’t consider before.”

Izuku thought about their new future together that was right around the horizon.

“And when they touch, they don’t want to let go of them.” He caressed Katsuki’s hand. “Then finally, they can’t imagine their life without them.”

It was all true, and exactly how he knew he was in love with Katsuki.

Katsuki nodded and smiled. “Thank you. That was helpful.”

“Of course!” Izuku giggled. He hugged one of his books as he thought about sharing more with his husband. “If you want to talk more about the books, let me know. Maybe we can even read them together. You have a great read out loud voice.”

“I might take you up on that offer, darling.”

Katsuki smiled and so did Izuku.



Izuku eventually began reading the start of a book. The day continued and they moved from the kitchen to the den. Izuku laid comfortably in his lap and Katsuki held him close the whole time. They draped a fluffy blanket over their bodies to counter the autumn chill in the air.

Katsuki casually watched TV as Izuku read in his arms.

As he was deep into chapter five of the new series, Katsuki randomly cleared his throat and reached out to take one of his hands. Izuku paused his reading and looked up at his husband, who was blushing deeper than he ever had before.

Izuku was about to ask him what was wrong, but before he could, an abrupt banging on their door occurred.

Both Izuku and Katsuki's heads whipped at the sudden sound and the banging grew louder and louder until it nearly sounded like the door cracked under pressure.

"Bakugou!" A loud voice Izuku had never heard before ripped through the air. "Bakugou, I saw your stupid ass hair's silhouette in the window. Open up, otherwise we're kicking this door down!"

Alarm immediately surged through Izuku. It sounded like whoever this was intended on killing Katsuki.

"Shit," Katsuki hissed. "Shit. Shit. Shit."

He scrambled upright and Izuku did too. Izuku stared at Katsuki confused, searching for an answer to what was happening but Katsuki didn't say a word as he frantically looked around the den. Did Katsuki make an enemy somewhere in his career that would've tracked him down? It would make sense—

"I know you hear me!" The voice yelled again, a lot shriller. "You're going to open up on the count of ten and I am dragging you back to HQ if it's the last thing I do. I am tired of cleaning up your mess!"

HQ? Izuku paused. This was someone Katsuki knew.

"Who is that?" Izuku harshly whispered.

"It's my fucking *coworker*," Katsuki groaned.

Izuku's mouth dropped in confusion. Why on earth was Katsuki's coworker banging down his door like he had no manners? Then suddenly the force of the banging grew more violent and Izuku was taken aback at the way the door nearly bent under the sheer force.

"One," The man started counting. "*Two*—"

Katsuki shot up, grabbed Izuku and hoisted him in his arms. Izuku gasped in shock as he dropped his book and was hurried out of the living room at record speed.

"What are you doing?!" Izuku yelped.

"Hiding you," Katsuki answered hastily.

"Hiding me? Why are you *hiding* me?" Izuku questioned.

Katsuki skidded around the corner quickly and darted straight for the bedroom. Izuku further sank into confusion as he looked around.

Katsuki stopped in front of the closet and swiftly opened the door with his foot.

“Because—”

“—*Five*!” Katsuki’s co-worker yelled impatiently. “*Six*!”

“Fuck,” Katsuki groaned and he swiftly put Izuku in the closet out of sight.

He scattered and grabbed two fists full of clothes off their hangers. He rapidly tossed them on top of Izuku in a poor attempt to conceal him and Izuku burned with unease. Would it be that big of a deal if they were seen together?

“I’ll explain later once I get them to go away,” Katsuki said as he plopped one more pile of clothes on Izuku. “Stay here and don’t let them see you under any circumstance, okay?”

Izuku had a sock on top of his head, staring at his husband like he was crazy. “I can’t meet your coworkers?”

“—*Eight*!” The coworker called again. “You’re about to have to replace your door, Bakugou!”

Katsuki made a pained face. “No, you can’t meet this one. He isn’t exactly *friendly*.”

“*Nine*!” The coworker’s voice was close to a pitch that could break glass.

At that tone, Izuku decided not to take it personally. Maybe whoever this was he didn’t want to meet anyways. What kind of person kicked down their colleagues door? Izuku nodded quickly and fell in line. He grabbed a bunch of sweaters off their hangers and began piling them on himself until he was fully invisible to the untrained eye.

Once Izuku was simply a pile of sloppily organized clothes, Katsuki slammed the closet door and hauled off.

Izuku sat in the darkness underneath all the dusty clothes as stiff as he could.

“*Ten*!” The coworker screamed.

Suddenly quietness filled the air.

Izuku could hear three distinct voices, one of them being Katsuki’s but he could barely make out the muffled words. He sat hidden in the dark, feeling oddly ashamed. As time passed, Izuku wondered how long this would take. Minutes? *Hours*?

Suddenly, a tickle brushed at his nose. Izuku wiggled his face and tried to push down the rising feeling of a sneeze. But the dust that was collected in the closet began forming together and filled into his airways. Izuku wanted to curse. Katsuki hadn’t done a very good job at cleaning out the closet it seemed like.

Izuku quickly put his hands over his mouth and nose and tried his best to stifle a tiny sneeze.

He froze and held his breath. It was barely audible and he hoped that no one would have heard that.

But of course, fate had her plans. Izuku screwed his eyes shut when he heard an unfamiliar set of footsteps creep into the bedroom. These were not Katsuki's footsteps. His lover had a confident stride and every time his shoe hit the ground, it was like he knew where he was going. These footsteps snuck into the room like they were trying to find something.

Quickly, Izuku's worst nightmare came true when the closet door slammed open. He stayed unbearably still as nothing happened. Then a hand rested on top of his covered head and peeled away the layer of clothes.

Immediately Izuku came face to face with a blond man with periwinkle eyes.

Izuku gave a sheepish, friendly wave at being caught. "Hello."

Quickly the stranger's face twisted with murderous intent.

"*You*," The man growled.

The hairs on Izuku's hair stood up and he quickly switched gears into his viper mode. He tried to ask for the man to wait but it was no use. A hand shot out and roughly grabbed him by his hair. Izuku yelled in surprise when he was dragged out of the closet and a swift uppercut connected with his jaw.

Pain blistered in his mouth with the taste of iron.

Izuku's eyes widened at the attack—Katsuki was right. This guy was *not* friendly.

Izuku rebounded and twisted the best he could out of the grasp with his disadvantage. He staggered as more vicious blows rained down on him and Izuku began fighting right back. They grappled at each other in a tussle of powerful punches and swift kicks. His world tipped on its side when he was suddenly thrown across the room into the dresser.

Izuku cried out as his spine bursted with sharp pain.

The furious blond charged at him and Izuku dodged, ducking under the man's arms. Izuku went on the defensive and quickly jabbed at the man's pressure points. He watched as the left side of the man's body seized up tightly and used the opportunity to slam his elbow into the side of his head.

Izuku moved to do the same to the right side of his body, but staggered as he tripped over his own cast.

Due to his disadvantage, the stranger recovered, and Izuku yelped as he was tackled out of the bedroom into the hallway.

Izuku's world flipped when he was whirled around like a frisbee and hurled to the ground with enormous strength. He slid on the newly polished floors, and cried out as his ankle cracked upon impact.

White spots danced across his vision.

Everything was happening too quickly. Izuku could barely grasp it. Why was this guy attacking him so intently inside of Katsuki's home? What did he do to *him*? Izuku winced as pain crackled through his body. He heard the cocking of a gun and whipped his head to see the man was wasting no time and aimed the barrel directly at him.

Izuku scrambled and rolled across the floor to dodge two swift bullets.

When Izuku stopped his motions he suddenly could see Katsuki staring wide eyed in horror at the scene. Next to him, there was a purple haired man gazing down at him with the same murderous contempt as the other stranger. The second man drew his gun, pointing it at Izuku. Izuku scrambled backwards, eyes wide and heart pounding. His leg throbbed all the way through and within two seconds, the blond man placed his gun directly on his forehead.

Izuku's eyes widened in fear.

Suddenly, a blur of Katsuki bum rushed the man about to kill him. Izuku flinched as Katsuki elbowed the man in the face and blood sprayed everywhere. Everyone in the room froze, and their eyes went wide.

The bullets meant for Izuku's skull whizzed past him and sank into the couch instead.

The blond man groaned in pain as his head was snapped backwards by the inordinate force used. The dark crimson liquid dripped from his nose, but that didn't stop Katsuki as he promptly disarmed the man and kicked him backwards on the ground.

Katsuki took the gun in his own hands and pointed it directly at the purple haired man as he stood between Izuku and the line of fire.

Both strangers stared at Katsuki in horror.

"What are you doing, Bakugou?!" The blond stranger yelled furiously. He cupped his now broken nose, attempting to halt the profuse bleeding. "I found him hiding in your closet—"

"—And what were you doing in my goddamn bedroom?" Katsuki snapped. He walked backwards, stationing his body directly in front of Izuku on the ground. He didn't take his sight off the purple haired stranger who never lowered his gun away from Izuku. "You said you needed to use the bathroom."

"I heard someone try to suppress a sneeze," the blond hissed and staggered upright. "And it turned out to be *him*! He's trying to kill you—"

"—He's not." Katsuki cocked the gun. "He's harmless."

The tension in the room prickled like needles. Each stab punctured the four men, and the pressure was suffocating as everyone surveyed each other. The two newcomers stood side by side in disbelief as Izuku slowly sat up on his hunches, entirely protected by Katsuki.

Izuku glanced up at Katsuki who was fiercely towering over him.

“Harmless?” The purple stranger parroted cynically. “This is the same guy you said you would gladly torture if you got the chance. You even detailed how you would skin him alive and tear off his fingernails. Move aside so we can get this over with.”

Izuku froze.

Katsuki said that?

“No. Back off.” Katsuki gritted his teeth and toyed with the trigger. “Point that gun elsewhere. *Now*. I’ll explain once you calm down.”

“You can’t be serious.” The purple haired man tried to reason once more. “Listen to me. This is clearly some type of ploy to kill you—”

“I said point the gun elsewhere,” Katsuki venomously warned.

“Bakugou. You’re really dancing the line here.”

“And I’ll dance right fucking over it in the next second if you don’t put your gun down.”

Silence stunned the room.

All eyes, including Izuku’s, were staring wide at Katsuki. Izuku was stuck between terror and realizing what was happening. Katsuki was defying some sort of order protecting him, and it was very clear these two men somehow knew who he was yet he had no clue who they were.

Suddenly, the lethal intent in the blond stranger’s eyes left the longer he stared at him. The man’s gaze flickered between Katsuki and Izuku as if piecing something together. His eyes narrowed in on the bruise along Katsuki’s jaw line that Izuku left the other night.

The man’s shoulders sagged. He sighed and grabbed the barrel of the other man’s gun. He slowly lowered it for his companion, who was now giving him a perplexed stare.

“They’re fucking,” the blond said. He turned to Katsuki and looked him dead in the eye. “Aren’t you?”

Izuku wearily stared up at Katsuki and Katsuki wearily stared down at Izuku. Neither of them spoke, but their eyes translated a thousand sentences.

“Oh. You’ve got to be *kidding* me,” the blond exasperated when he saw the lovesick stares. He groaned and threw his head back. “You’re *more* than fucking. Of course. Nothing is ever simple with you.”

At this, the other man seemed mortified. “Bakugou. Is that true?”

Katsuki lowered his gun and quietly helped Izuku off the floor. Izuku whimpered a little, lifting his ankle off the ground and leaned all the way into Katsuki. The two of them exchanged long stares and Izuku could feel as if this was something that was not supposed to be known.

He waited for Katsuki to deflect based on the look in his eyes, but instead his husband wrapped his arm around his midriff to help balance him. He turned back to his coworkers.

“We’re involved, yes,” Katsuki said firmly.

The blond man flew a hand up and turned around. The purple haired man stared at Katsuki like he grew a second head.

“This is debauched,” the purple haired man accused. “You’re seriously trusting your dick to the guy who has tried to kill you for eight years?”

“He never tried to really kill me,” Katsuki corrected and Izuku was happy Katsuki finally understood that. “And we’re officially done with all of that. Things between us are… complicated.”

“Cursed,” the blond stranger corrected. “Things between you are *cursed*.” He walked into the kitchen and shoved paper towels up his nostrils to collect the blood. “And what about Aizawa? Did you even stop and consider what would happen if he found out about this match made in hell? He’s going to beat your ass.”

Izuku recognized the name Aizawa as the name of Katsuki’s supervisor.

His husband told him about his supervisor that night in the nursery and suddenly this all made dreadful, awful sense. Somehow Izuku never considered that even though he kept Katsuki’s existence a secret from his family, that didn’t mean Katsuki had done the same.

His coworkers and supervisor probably knew him as Deku.

“This is why I haven’t called to check in,” Katsuki explained. “Him and I have figured out some stuff between us. It’s a lot to explain but Aizawa will understand once I tell it all.”

“No, Bakugou. He won’t,” the purple haired coworker spoke. The look of eerie caution in his eyes was ignited high. “Aizawa understands a lot of things, but *this*—” He angrily waved his hand at Izuku. “—Will *not* be one of them. You weren’t there when he gave out the kill orders. Aizawa wants this *pest* dead for some other reason that he said he can’t disclose. This is no longer an issue between the two of you, it’s a company issue. Plus, he killed Rin Hiryu. How could you forgive him for that?”

Izuku stiffened at the mention of his dead brother.

But worse, he realized there were *kill* orders against him.

Instantly, Izuku’s defenses went through the roof and his viper was raised awake. This was no longer a simple run in or misunderstanding. These men wanted him dead—and Izuku could not afford to die right now. He was poised in a way that was partially behind Katsuki and his hand was curled into a fist, ready to strike.

“I’ll make him understand,” Katsuki said and he held on to Izuku harder. “Once I explain it to him—”

"—If you explain anything to Aizawa, he will *kill* your homicidal boyfriend," The blond quipped. He wasn't looking at any of them as he leaned over the sink. His shoulders crept up to his neck and he gripped the counter until his hands were white. "…Are you happy, Bakugou?"

No one expected the question.

Katsuki recoiled, and the purple haired coworker turned his head towards the other at the strangeness.

Izuku weighed what was happening. Whoever the blond was, his body language shifted and he was assessing what exactly him and Katsuki were. Izuku wearily glanced at Katsuki, unsure what his answer might be.

Katsuki looked back at him with the purest of expressions. "Yes. The happiest I've ever been."

Izuku's heart squeezed. He wanted to say '*I am too*' but he knew him chiming in would help nothing.

The blond coworker nodded silently. He strummed his fingers.

"Then you will keep this a secret," the blond said unhappily. He turned around with an understanding expression but he cut his eyes towards Izuku with intense distrust. "And we will keep this to ourselves too. If this shit runs into the ground then so be it, that's your mess to clean up. But otherwise, this whole fiasco between the four of us never occurred."

"*What*?" The other coworker hissed. He whirled on his companion, face twisting in anger. "Have you lost your goddamn mind? We're not keeping this a secret from Aizawa—"

"Yes. We are." The blond coworker shot a challenging glare.

They stood in an intensely matched grid lock. Izuku could nearly see the electricity between them zap in dominating jolts. It roared up and down, and they quietly pushed each other in a way that only people who knew each other well could do.

The blond co-worker walked up to the other with his shoulders squared out. On his face was a raw, sternly angry but soft emotion.

"Let him be happy," the blond murmured, nearly inaudible.

That seemed to be the ice water on the fire. Slowly, the purple haired coworker's anger snuffed out and he looked at Katsuki in a new light. There was a kinship there as Katsuki silently pleaded with him too. Then the man's eyes assessed Izuku with unease.

"Fine," The purple haired coworker agreed without looking at anyone. He pushed his gun back in his holster and folded his arms, fuming. "If this goes wrong—*which it will*—don't fucking come to us about it, Bakugou. We can keep this a secret between us on one condition: you're coming back with us tonight to HQ. You're going to close out immediately."

“Okay. I’ll come with you,” Katsuki agreed.

“We’ll be waiting on the porch,” the blond coworker said. He began to push his companion by the shoulder towards the door. “Take all the time you need.”

The two left, leaving Izuku and Katsuki alone.

Izuku uncurled his fist and Katsuki sagged his shoulders. They both stared down at Izuku’s ankle and gradually the weight of what had just happened sunk in.

“C’mon, let’s get that fixed up before I go,” Katsuki whispered. He lifted Izuku in his arms with regret heavy on his mind. “Sorry he threw you like that.”

Izuku couldn’t reply.

The weight of feeling like a burden was heavy against his mind.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku watched from the bed as Katsuki quietly packed a backpack for all the things he needed for an overnight trip.

He took his cellphone, keys and wallet and even an extra pair of clothes. Next, he moved to pull out a giant suitcase and briefcase that was full of different types of guns and weapons. The deadly steel shone under the light of their bedroom and Izuku was promptly reminded that Katsuki’s deadly era was coming to an end.

Then with a heavy heart, Izuku watched Katsuki take off his wedding ring.

It was like being pushed into the deep end of a pool. Izuku had been ignoring that they weren’t *really* married this whole time, and he didn’t want to acknowledge the green tint that was slowly growing on his finger from the cheap metal.

Izuku toyed with his wedding band as he thought about the kill orders hanging over his head. He wondered how long had Katsuki been given the instruction to take his life? He knew he shouldn’t be upset over such a thing. It made sense. He got in the way of Katsuki’s missions many times, and Katsuki very bluntly exclaimed he was going to kill him in Vienna, Taiwan, and during countless other encounters.

But now that he was so deep in love, the concept made Izuku uneasy.

“Will you be okay by yourself?” Katsuki asked as he put on his leather jacket.

“I will,” Izuku said with a forced smile. “I didn’t know I caused you so much trouble. I’m sorry.”

“Don’t worry about it,” Katsuki reassured. He walked around the bed to sit next to Izuku. He placed his hand on top of Izuku’s and squeezed it. “Those assholes will get over it and what my supervisor doesn’t know won’t hurt him. I’ll get the kill order stuff sorted out too.”

Izuku's smile faltered. He pinned up a fake smile the next moment.

"Okay, Kacchan."

Katsuki gave him a loving kiss and patted his head. Izuku watched sadly as Katsuki parted away from him and left. He heard the footsteps of the man he loved fade and the front door closed shut. Izuku looked down at the birthday slash he was still wearing and felt his heart hum low.

He slowly took it off and looked at it plainly.

He and Katsuki were always good at playing pretend, weren't they? They played pretend husbands as kids and in Okinawa. Even now, they somehow were legally married but still pretending like the weight of the world wasn't outside ready to rip them away from each other. It wasn't even Izuku's birthday, but they pretended like it was for the sake of it.

Izuku wondered if they would ever have the chance to stop playing pretend.

ᔓᔓᔓ

That night, Katsuki didn't come home. It was odd to be alone again after so long. Izuku tossed and turned all night and shivered despite not being cold. He desperately wanted to hear Katsuki's voice, but he realized he didn't have a phone number to call. He only wanted to ask if he was alright but he didn't have any information to do so.

In fact, he didn't actually have much information about Katsuki besides this address.

Izuku apprehensively dwelled on this. What *would* happen to them after this? Could they keep on pretending on weekends and Izuku's off weeks? Would that be fair to Katsuki to keep him in some half baked relationship when he could go on being normal with someone who could actually provide all their attention? Truthfully, no. It wouldn't be fair.

Izuku turned his head to the side to glance at his duffle bag. He thought about the locket that held his tracker.

He chewed on his bottom lip as the stress he'd been ignoring the last three months gnawed its way up his throat. He began analyzing various scenarios and found some hopeful cracks. He *had* successfully gotten away with disappearing for three months. And Katsuki cared about him just as much.

Maybe they really *could* find a way to be in a relationship—

Suddenly, a strange sound echoed from outside of the bedroom.

Izuku sat upright instantly. He cut his eye to the door when he heard an odd metallic clattering. He knew it couldn't be Katsuki. His husband would have walked straight through the door and announced he was back in order to disarm Izuku.

When it sounded like something dropped to the ground *inside* the house, all Izuku's viper instincts snapped into place.

Izuku slowly peeled away the covers and carefully reached for the nightstand on his side of the bed. He grabbed his gun out of the first drawer and checked to make sure it was loaded with bullets. Six. He made sure to keep that in mind as he cocked his weapon when the noise drew closer.

Izuku swung his legs off the side of the bed and stood up.

He was mindful of the way his casted ankle dragged and used his well trained leg muscles to keep it hovered off the ground. The deadly venom in his veins made his eyes fully constrict to see perfectly in the dark. Without making a noise, he slid open the door to the bedroom. He kept his gun forward as he checked around every corner on high alert.

By the time he made it to the kitchen, Izuku's mind was reeling. There was a window with a lock snapped off but no person to be found.

Who would be breaking in?

He figured it would be Katsuki's coworkers again. They might've lured Katsuki away and circled back to finish the job on their kill orders like good, loyal hitmen would.

But Izuku got his answer of '*who*' when suddenly all the hairs on his neck stood up.

Izuku cut his eye down the long, dark hallway on his right. He leaned his head four millimeters to the side at the sound of a knife cutting through air. It whizzed directly past his ear, slicing the split ends of his hairs and sunk into the drywall behind his head.

Izuku's eyes narrowed when Himiko emerged from the shadows with her signature grin.

"Long time no see, baby brother," Himiko said. "Glad to see your vacation didn't make you lazy."

The very last thread of ignorant bliss Izuku was holding on to slipped away.

Himiko was back in Japan, and she was here in *Biei*. Izuku's eyes darkened and he positioned himself on the offensive. He didn't lower his gun as he studied his deadly sibling across the way.

"What are you doing here?" Izuku asked without any friendliness, and his heart rate sped up slightly. "I thought you were in Bangkok until January."

"I was supposed to be," Himiko said with a shrug. She tilted her head to the side and put her hand on her hip. "I finished a while ago. Imagine my surprise when I got word that you haven't been home in months and imagine how even *more* surprised I was to learn everyone thought *you* were the one on the Bangkok mission."

Izuku gritted his teeth and his heart rate sped up. He wasn't ready to leave. He didn't *want* to leave, he wanted to stay here so *badly* with Katsuki but he knew his time was now officially

thin if Himiko was making her appearance.

Suddenly, Izuku felt the shadows of Hadeus stretch across Japan and begin to pull him back to Tokyo.

“I didn’t say anything by the way,” Himiko snarked. “It was a nice vacation of my own to be home without the stench of your cologne clogging up the hallways.”

“So now what? You came all this way to drag me back?” Izuku asked.

“Oh, please,” Himiko exasperated. “You really think *I* was the one who gave two shits about you disappearing?”

A single footstep changed the whole mood.

Izuku’s skin crawled with goosebumps as his eyes cut down the blackened hallway.

Out from the shadows came Tomura. His mouth was taut and his hands were behind his back. All the venom in his eyes was directed to Izuku as he walked forward.

“Hello, Izuku,” Tomura said. “Seems like you’ve been resting up well after expending all that energy to lie to me.”

Izuku hobbled backwards and his back hit the wall. Fear stronger than anything he ever felt gripped the length of his spine and twisted it under the sheer gravity of how screwed he was. Tomura was standing in Katsuki’s kitchen and rolling off of him in waves was a subzero temperature that threatened to brutally kill anything he laid eyes on.

And his eyes were directly on Izuku.

Immediately, Izuku tensed up and he hung his head away. He screwed his eyes shut, waiting for Tomura’s unchecked wrath that was surely going to rain down on him. He waited. Then waited some more.

Then carefully, he peaked open an eye when nothing occurred. Tomura was watching him with such a blank expression Izuku had no clue what was actually going through his head.

Tomura finally made a move, and both him and Himiko flinched slightly. But it was nothing because all Tomura did was flick on the light.

Brightness poured all around the kitchen and Izuku immediately shielded his eyes from the sudden shift. He rapidly blinked, waiting for something to happen. He watched, fully on guard as Tomura finally looked away from him.

His brother strolled around, looking at the dirty dishes and the various foods that were sitting out on the counter. Tomura then swiped his finger on the seat of one of the kitchen chairs. He inspected his finger for any collected dust before sitting down and crossing his legs. He folded his hands on the table and returned his eyes into Izuku.

Izuku stayed silent. Himiko wearily looked at Tomura as well.

He was far too calm.

“Aren’t you going to make us tea?” Tomura impatiently asked. He gestured to the pot on the stove. “It’s rude to not offer any hospitality to family after we’ve traveled all this way.”

This was a ticking bomb.

Izuku hesitated. But then he did like he was asked. Without a word, Izuku hobbled towards the stove silently and began making the tea. He played down the gun on the counter and then discreetly slid the wedding ring off his hand. He gulped heavily as he tried his best to not be suspicious and hide the ring in the cabinet as he grabbed a tea packet.

He knew sencha was Tomura’s favorite so he pulled out that one as his breathing skipped. He poured water into the pot with shaking hands and turned on the fire. It flickered and danced in the dim lighting under the tension in the room.

When the tea was properly prepared and ready, Izuku made two cups.

He handed one to Tomura and one to Himiko quietly.

A small throb in his ankle told him it was time to sit down. He did so slowly, choosing a chair directly across from Tomura. Himiko stood behind Tomura’s chair with curious eyes as she sipped on her tea. Tomura sipped the first bit of his tea and rolled his shoulders. He enjoyed his tea in silence as Izuku drowned in horrible anxiety, waiting for his brother to snap.

Then Tomura placed the cup down and folded his hands.

“Izuku,” Tomura said calmly. He tilted his head and narrowed his eyes. “What do you think you’re doing?”

“I’m…resting up,” Izuku admitted. He fiddled with the hems of his sleeves. “I hurt my ankle on the mission and wanted private time to heal.”

“Aoyama did say you were checked into an AirBnb,” Tomura replied slowly and looked down to Izuku’s ankle. “And it does seem like you *actually* hurt yourself. So you do need the time off.”

Tomura sipped his tea again. He then put down the porcelain cup and his expression twisted with rage.

“But this is *not* an AirBnB,” Tomura venomously pointed out. “This estate is registered to a Bakugou Katsuki, who just left here a couple hours ago. He is twenty five. Born in Tokyo and works for a so called laundry mat that handles ‘dirty business’ when it’s really a disguise for a hitman agency.”

Izuku seized up and all the blood in his face drained.

“And he’s *blond*,” Tomura added distastefully. “How long have you been dating him?”

Izuku shook his head quickly. “I-I’m not, we’re n-not together—”

“—Don’t lie to me right now, Izuku. It’ll only make things worse.” Tomura tightened his hand on the tea cup. “I pulled a picture of him and Himiko confirmed that he was the loose end she saw you hesitate to kill all those years ago. How long?”

Izuku glanced at Himiko and she averted her eyes.

Izuku held his breath and clutched his hands in his lap. He tried his best to hold back his tears as he knew crying in front of Tomura would help nothing. He blinked rapidly, and his heart hammered its way into his throat.

“We only recently started g-getting to know each other,” Izuku whispered with a half truth. “We connected in Okinawa after recognizing each other from various assignments. He offered to let me stay here until my ankle healed. We’ve been…spending time together but we’re not in a relationship.”

Tomura’s sub zero stare dropped to lethal lows. “What is our number one rule, Izuku?”

“No contact with outsiders,” Izuku answered quietly.

“And *why* do we have this rule?”

“Because outsiders are cruel, greedy and vicious people. They would think we’re monsters, and try to hurt us.”

“Exactly,” Tomura replied back viciously. “You are a *viper*, Izuku. No one understands vipers *except* other vipers. Any casual contact with the outside world puts our entire family at jeopardy—it puts *you* at jeopardy. Staying here with this *stranger* is directly putting your life at risk. I have spent too much fucking time saving your ass over and over again for you to carelessly do something like this.”

“I’m sorry,” Izuku replied. “I-I only wanted to get to know him.”

“Why?” Tomura snapped back. “Why was it *so* important for you to get to know this man that you put the deal with Chisaki on hold for months, have the audacity to lie to me, and on top of that you dragged Aoyama into your goddamn mess?”

“I—” Izuku stuttered. *I love him.* “I only wanted to get to know him. I was going to come back once my ankle healed. I figured it would be harmless to rest here instead of home. Chisaki wouldn’t want me in my broken state anyways.”

“What a stupid conclusion,” Tomura cut down. “Did you ever consider that this stranger would hurt you if he knew *what* you were?”

“But he wouldn’t hurt me,” Izuku replied earnestly. He shook his head, and love sick thoughts clouded his thoughts. “He’s similar to us—”

“—*Similar*? Do you really think he would ever look at you like you are similar to him?”

That struck a chord.

“He already does,” Izuku said with wavering confidence. “You said so yourself he worked for a hitman agency he won’t bat an eye about how many people I’ve killed. He’d be accepting of it. He'd be accepting of *me*.”

Tomura halted at that.

He raised a brow, and straightened his back. He then quietly assessed Izuku with his head sideways, as if connecting two dots. His brows furrowed deeply and his eyes shifted to a cold, unwavering glare.

“Izuku…Do you view this man romantically? Answer yes or no.”

Izuku didn’t say anything right away. He stared at his brother and his frigid gaze bored back into him. Izuku could tell Tomura already knew the answer.

“Y-Yes,” Izuku whispered. He realized where this was going and his heart plummeted into the darkest part of his body. “Pl-Please don’t hurt him. *Please*. I’ll do anything but don’t touch him. I-It was my idea to come here with him. He doesn’t know anything.”

Himiko looked at him like he had gone mad but Izuku pushed forward. He didn’t care how much he had to grovel, or if he needed to get on his knees and beg. He would happily give his body to Chisaki if it meant Katsuki remained out of reach from his blood thirsty family.

“Why would you offer to protect a stranger like this?” Himiko whispered, her eyes were stretched wide. “This guy would never do the same for you.”

“Because he loves him,” Tomura answered simply and Izuku’s stomach dropped. “He’s the blond boy you mentioned that morning of The Incident, isn’t he?”

“He is,” Izuku said. He pressed his lips in a thing line and curled his fists. “And I mean what I said. Please, don’t touch him. I don’t care what you make me do but stay away from him.”

Tomura scoffed and rolled his eyes. “There it is, the root of this delusion. You probably have made yourself believe that he cares for you, right? All because you knew each other as kids for a measly amount of time?”

There was something sinister about the way Tomura proposed the question.

Izuku nodded, unsure where this was going.

Izuku quietly said, “I know he cares about me.” He mustered up some of the courage Katsuki had gifted him as he found his voice to talk about what he wanted. “M-Maybe everything we were taught about outsiders wasn’t all the way true. There can be exceptions and Katsuki is one of the few people who cares about me like you do—”

“—Enough.” Tomura held his hand up.

Tomura then reached down into his leather satchel.

He exhaled tiredly and revealed several red folders. He slammed them on the table with a reverberating force that made Izuku jump slightly. The color on all of the folders were faded slightly and they had wear that was indicative of them being old.

Izuku stared at the folders, not understanding where this was going anymore.

“If you want to test how much he *cares* for you, then show him this,” Tomura said calmly.

Tomura slid the first red folder in front of Izuku.

Izuku took it with caution. He apprehensively stared at Tomura who stared right back with all the patience in the world. Izuku opened it up and froze. He blinked. Clipped to the top of the stack of papers was an old photograph. He had seen once before for a brief period of time five years ago. He vaguely remembered seeing this on the night before The Incident after Himiko had tauntingly waved it in his face.

It was a worn photograph of a blond woman with red eyes holding pink carnations.

Izuku was confused why Tomura had brought this but stiffened the longer he stared at the photograph. As he studied it, suddenly an eerie family resemblance settled in that he didn't have the time to register before. Katsuki’s face overlapped on top of hers perfectly. The high cheek bones. The lopsided smirk. The dangerously sharp red eyes. Even their hair was the exact same shade of ash blond.

Dread, fear, and horror sunk in like three blades into Izuku’s core. He inched his eyes over to read the name.

Bakugou Mitsuki.

A gut punch like no other slammed into him and all the air was rocked out of his lungs.

Chapter End Notes

And here we goooooooooo! *rubs my angsty little hands together* Buckle in!! We're diving straight into hell :) Please let me know what you think below!! I am SO excited for the next string of chapters. Next one is the last Honeymoon recap and then it'll flip right into present and we're going for a roller coaster right into hell :^D

See you in the New Year!! :)

Chapter 26: Legato

Chapter Summary

Legato - (style indicator) Smooth and connected.

Everything becomes connected in the end.

Chapter Notes

Hellooo! Welcome back to this very special chapter that is officially the end of the recap from Izuku's POV. :)) I was super excited to write all of this and see everyone's reactions!!

Buckle in :)) and also be sure to check out the songs for this chapter! I've been really excited to share them because i think all three fit super well. :)

Warnings: Heavy warning on the angst

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 26 — Legato

.

.

.

“No,” Izuku whispered. He gripped the red folder in his hands so tightly that his fingernail markings etched into the material. Pieces of paper crumbled under his grasp and Izuku’s spirit was overtaken with terrible understanding. “N-No, th-there’s no way th-this is true. Th-this *can’t* be t-true.”

But it was.

He re-lived it all. He knew how her blood sprayed when the bullet exited through her skull. He knew exactly the way her fragile body hit the ground and how her eyes rolled back. Each detail was stamped into his memory because this particular assignment is what kicked off Tomura’s ascension to power.

He killed *Bakugou Mitsuki*.

He killed Katsuki's *mother*.

He struggled to believe it. Izuku thought about all the promises he made to Katsuki in the past about how he would kill Chizome for him. Yet they had both gotten it wrong—the real killer had been right in the room with them the whole time.

Izuku forgot to breathe while he stared at the documents. When he remembered to, his chest was tight. Izuku sharply inhaled and slowly covered his mouth with his hand in horror.

Izuku knew he was a snake who caused countless funerals. Infinite coffins were stacked on top of each other every time he bared his fangs and put a tally mark in his book. But he never imagined Katsuki's mother was one of those tally marks. His dreams of a future with Katsuki broke and scattered like fragile glass as he tried to grasp what he had done.

He tried to think of a million different ways to tell Katsuki the truth but all he saw was whirlpools of endless *pain*.

Tomura stood up. He walked behind Izuku and placed a heavy hand on Izuku's shoulder. He then said, "Do you really think your precious blond would still love you if you told him you were the one to kill his mother?"

Izuku grasped for straws.

"B-But Chisaki," Izuku whispered, breathless. His eyes began to burn as tears poured down. "Ch-Chisaki is the one who ordered the hit. I only pulled the trigger—h-he'll understand—"

"—No. He won't." Tomura gave a true look of pity like an older brother. "He's not going to see it any differently, Izuku. You both are going to be guilty in his eyes, maybe not symmetrically but still guilty. The hitman and the requester are both to blame when someone is killed."

Tomura slid over the other folders on the table.

One by one Tomura opened them and forced Izuku to look at each and every picture. What was waiting inside were some of the most gruesome images Izuku ever laid sights on. Countless men were photographed in the dark with disfigured bodies. Each one was bloodied, maimed, and missing some sort of limb.

There were at least fifty bodies in total. One included a man cut deeply in his intestines, the knife was left behind with a note and part of his face was dissolved by acid. His long neck was unnaturally bent with bones sticking out.

"All of these are cases Bakugou Katsuki was hired for within the last three years," Tomura explained. "Some of his more secretive assignments that his company agreed to and he was paid a *handsome* amount of money to pull off. Did you know his specialities are torture and hunting?"

Izuku thought about what Katsuki said while tormenting Koizumi.

“I specialize in tracking and torture. It’s a selling point of my portfolio that I never leave a loose end.”

Tomura plucked a particularly lurid photo from the stack and held it up.

“He’s a loose cannon already nicknamed The Scarlet Eyed Killer,” Tomura said with heavy caution. “What he did to his own biological father will be *light* in comparison to what he’ll do to you when he finds out you put the bullet in his mother. And I don’t even want to think about what would happen to Chisaki. This man will kill everyone involved in his mother’s death—and you are included in that. He will not spare you if this gets back to him.”

Izuku began trembling.

His whole spirit, body and mind were quaking down to the last fiber as he wrestled with coming to terms with what the real truth was. He replayed that night again and again and again in his head and the more details he recalled, the worse it became.

As Izuku stayed paralyzed in his memories, Tomura sighed and began packing up the folders. He shook his head and gave Izuku’s shoulder a tiny, sympathetic pat.

“This is why we do not mingle with people outside of our circles, Izuku,” Tomura lectured. “You never know who will want you dead for what you’ve done. It’s unfortunate you’ve fallen in love with him, but you will get over it with time. Now, clean up the dishes and I’ll take a look at your ankle so I can decide what to do next.”

White noise cut through Izuku’s eardrums.

“You killed the mother of the only person who cared for you so purely,” the voice of Hiryu harshly whispered in the back of his head. “You don’t deserve him.”

As if he was a wind-up toy, he proceeded to do as Tomura said while dazed. Hot, burning tears rolled down his face as he stayed deathly silent. He made no move to speak or engage with either of his siblings as he gathered the empty tea cups and brought them over to the sink.

He washed the cups silently as his tears rained down into the dishwater. In the ripples he saw his and Katsuki’s life. He re-lived pulling that trigger and he saw that bullet shattering Katsuki’s heart in the process.

Izuku terribly wondered how much Katsuki cried when he discovered her body.

The burden of murder weighed Izuku down until he leaned over the sink. Lightheadedness rolled over him and his limbs went numb. His head dropped below his shoulders as he clutched the tiny tea cups in his hands.

What had he done?

“What is that on your shoulder?” Himiko suddenly asked.

Without warning, a small finger hooked under his shirt collar. Cold air hit Izuku's back as the fabric was pulled down. Izuku recoiled quickly, snapping his body against the opposite side of the counter. He slapped a hand over the area and stared at Himiko with wide, horrified eyes.

A chill stabbed into his side when he realized what she saw.

Katsuki had left a trail of love bites along his shoulder last night.

She was staring at him in shock. Izuku's heart palpitated and he rapidly shook his head to warn her not to say anything—but it was too late.

"Holy shit—did you finally get laid?" Himiko exclaimed with humor, not understanding the weight of what she said.

"*What*?" Tomura viciously cut in.

Both Izuku and Himiko turned to see Tomura at the table glaring into Izuku like never before. Izuku immediately pressed himself further into the counter. He stumbled as all the color drained from his face and his stomach dropped to new lows.

"N-No, she's wrong," Izuku quickly lied but it was pointless.

Tomura stormed over, pushed Himiko aside and yanked Izuku forward by his shirt. Himiko staggered backwards, confused.

"Wait, is that bad?" Himiko questioned.

She furrowed her brows looking between the two of them waiting for an answer. But she never was acknowledged as Tomura was deadlocked on Izuku.

Quickly, Izuku began rambling apologies, excuses, lies—anything he could think of to spare himself but it was pointless. Tomura pulled down his shirt to the side to expose his shoulder. Izuku tried to fight it and struggled against Tomura as tears blurred his vision.

Then the sound of fabric stretching and seams breaking tore through everyone's ears.

All the evidence of Izuku's and Katsuki's forbidden intimacy was put on full display.

Tomura's nostrils flared.

"You fucking *slut*," Tomura seethed through his gritted teeth.

Izuku had never seen Tomura lose it so fast. Usually Tomura was cold and calculated with his anger, but this time it was boiling and impulsive as if he'd been pushed to the brink.

When the slap came, pain splintered everywhere on Izuku's face.

It held all of Tomura's strength and viciously turned his head with so much force that he fell to the ground instantly. His stomach became nauseous from the velocity his body was moved.

In the next moment, before he could even open his eyes, Tomura's hand was sinking into his hair and twisting it in a vicious death grip.

Izuku screamed in pain as he was dragged by his hair across the floor. He sunk his fingernails into Tomura's hands, kicking the whole way trying to get him to let go.

Horror at what was to come dawned on Izuku as the back door was kicked open. His eyes snapped open to see Himiko following, entirely confused at what was occurring. Izuku was dragged down the stairs and out into the open field of higanbana flowers. One by one, Tomura's feet destroyed them along the way in his spiteful stampede.

Izuku twisted his head to see where Tomura was heading—and much to his horror, in the distance he could see Tomura's black car parked off the side of a dirt road.

"N-No!" Izuku screamed. "*Please*! Stop!"

"Quit struggling!" Tomura yelled and gave Izuku's hair a harsh tug. "This shit ends now! You're coming back to Tokyo *today*!"

Izuku twisted his body. He struggled against his brother as he was pulled harder. Izuku dug his bare heels in the dirt as he tried to make himself heavier with force.

"N-Not yet! Please! Not yet!" Izuku yelled at the top of his lungs.

"Shut up!" Tomura snapped. "This proves you're incapable of making smart decisions, Izuku! What about the deal with Chisaki! *Huh*?! You gave away something that can't be taken back! What'll happen when Chisaki can tell!"

"He won't be able to," Izuku quickly replied. He shook his head desperately with wide eyes. "I promise he won't!"

"You shouldn't be promising *anything*. All that complaining you did and you still ran off and behaved like a damn whore. You have hickies from that serial killer all over your body. What if someone else sees these marks and it gets back around to him?! *Hah*? Did you think about that?!"

"Then let me stay here until they heal," Izuku tried to bargain. His heart sank as they came to the middle of the field and closer to the car. He shook his head and threw his body to the side as hard as he could. "Don't make me go back just yet, please! I-I can't leave him Tomura—I can't. He'll be hurt—"

"—So fucking what?! He will hurt *you*!"

Tomura whirled around towards Izuku with fury burning in his eyes. His lips curled back as he finally stopped his stride. He let go of Izuku and squatted down to his place in the dirt. He leaned in and his eyes darkened from the shadow eclipsing his frightening features.

Izuku shakily lifted himself up on his arms and hissed when Tomura roughly grabbed his face. As Tomura's fingers dug into his jaw, Izuku's heart pounded nearly out of his chest.

“After everything I’ve done to protect you, do you think I would lie about this, you stupid slut?” Tomura harshly questioned. He shook Izuku’s head as if trying to knock sense into his skull by force. “That man will gut you from the inside out and chop your body up. Think! Fucking *think* with your head for once! He doesn’t have any allegiance to you, he will flip on you when he discovers you killed his *mother*!”

“He won’t—he won’t hurt me,” Izuku whispered.

He believed it with all his heart as memories of him and Katsuki’s beautiful time spent together flickered through his head. All the memories were tainted now however. Each lovely memory shifted from bright vibrant colors to be stained with the crimson red blood of Bakugou Mitsuki. Sickness slid up Izuku’s throat as he thought about how much he directly hurt Katsuki.

“I’ll tell him the truth and whatever happens, *happens*,” Izuku whispered painfully.

He could feel Katsuki’s pain from finding out the truth already seared into him. It would be full of agony and the pain that would be wedged between them would be as wide as an ocean.

Izuku knew he would probably lose Katsuki after this—the love of his life would probably never talk to him again. And Katsuki would be very well within his right not to. But Izuku didn’t believe Katsuki would hurt him in the way Tomura was insisting.

“He-He’s soft with me,” Izuku said with a crack in his voice. “He wouldn’t hurt me if he knew the *full* truth. Not after everything we shared—he won’t hurt me like you think. He’s different.”

Silence.

Tomura stared at him with not an ounce of understanding.

“Just because he fucks you doesn’t mean he cares about you,” Tomura said slowly and evenly.

Izuku recoiled and shifted uncomfortably. It felt wrong to have that part of his life picked at by his brother, and the part of his brain that did take Tomura’s warnings seriously began to unfortunately listen.

Because Tomura always somehow knew best in the end.

“He will *never* care about someone like you,” Tomura warned. “He merely lusts after your body because that’s how men *are*. They lie and say sweet words so you give yourself to them without hesitation. That’s what I have been protecting you from for *years*.”

Izuku screwed his eyes shut and shook his head. Tomura quickly stilled his movements by tightening his grip on his chin.

“Why do you think I discouraged you from having sex for as long as possible?” Tomura continued and his tone became harsher. “Or why do you think I took a whole damn *year* to shift through men who *may* be well suited for you? Do you think I did it for the hell of it? No.

I did it because your bleeding heart would easily confuse lust as love and I wanted to protect you from heartbreak. And this thing with this Bakugou man proves I was *right* to keep you from all of this."

"No," Izuku bit back bravely. He shook his head but something inside of him tilted uneasily at what Tomura said. "Katsuki isn't like that. He's honest and sweet—"

"Oh, spare me. He's an average fucking man," Tomura scoffed. He narrowed his eyes and tilted his head. "With the way you look, do you really think he didn't consider shortcuts to get in your pants like everyone else around you has? He's no better than the cat callers on the street you've been rejecting for years. And the second he finds out you killed his mother, the thread of infatuation that's binding you two together will break." Tomura snapped his fingers. "Just like that."

Izuku unfortunately could image it.

He could see the weight of the truth breaking what he and Katsuki shared into thousands of unsalvageable pieces. Katsuki would cry. He would cuss. He would scream and rightfully lash out. But worst of all, he would break down into a void of sadness that Izuku never wanted him to endure ever in his life.

He only wanted the best for Katsuki and now Izuku knew that it wasn't him.

For some reason, that was the thought that tore him apart.

Izuku began to shake and all the heaviness of the situation finally made him buckle. He lowered his head forcefully away from his brother. He was fearful of showing this much emotion in front of Tomura, but he couldn't stop the waves from coming even if he tried. Because when it came to Katsuki, Izuku was nothing more than a human.

Izuku sobbed so loudly he shocked himself and Tomura.

He tried to cover his mouth with his hands but several more ugly sobs slipped past his fingers. He dropped his head between his trembling shoulders and screwed his eyes shut. Tears slid over his face, hands, and down his cheeks onto the petals of the higanbanas beneath him.

He cried his heart out in front of his brother as the ache in his chest grew as large as a black hole. The pain threatened to swallow him whole and he wished he could undo what he'd done to Katsuki.

For some reason, Tomura let him cry.

Tomura didn't speak, scold him or make him stop. Tomura let Izuku humiliate himself with his sadness pinned on full display for anyone to see and hear. It reminded Izuku of the time when he was thirteen and had freshly found out about Inko.

And exactly like when he was thirteen, his brother exhaled roughly and sat back on his hunches.

Izuku dared to open his eyes and he saw Tomura's empty eyes fill up with pity—true pity. The emotionless veil lifted from over Tomura's face to reveal sympathy so profound Izuku never knew he held it inside of him.

Izuku suddenly felt small and unsure.

Tomura leaned in and ran his calloused fingers through Izuku's hair. The touch comforted Izuku in a horrible, familiar way and his crying turned from sobbing to softly weeping.

They sat there and his brother gave him an inch of the mercy he somehow retained solely for Izuku. Tomura let Izuku cry for however long he needed as they sat on the open field together. The wind howled in the background and Izuku could do nothing but mourn the relationship he and Katsuki barely had the chance to start.

"You really do love him, don't you?" Tomura muttered quietly.

Izuku whispered, "I've loved him my whole life."

Tomura pressed his lips in a thin line at that confession. He shifted to sitting cross legged and tiredly rubbed the bridge of his nose. He studied Izuku carefully and then looked down to his ankle. He reached forward to touch it and made a quiet calculation in his head.

Tomura then cut his eyes across the field to the estate.

Izuku followed his gaze and stiffened when he saw Himiko standing there with wide, shocked eyes. The wind tousled through her golden hair as the moon painted light across her delicate features.

She heard the whole thing.

"Himiko, go inside before you catch a cold," Tomura suddenly commanded.

She looked between the two brothers and did as she was told. She put on her emotionless mask and closed the door behind her.

"I'll let you stay here until your ankle is healed on three conditions," Tomura said once Himiko was inside. "But you must follow the conditions fully. Are we clear?"

Izuku's sniffling slowed up and he snapped his head upright in shock. He stared at his brother, confused but was not about to question it.

"W-We're clear," Izuku quickly agreed.

Tomura dipped his hand into his pocket and pulled out a small, red handkerchief. He began wiping Izuku's tears from his face with a tinge of disgust.

"The first is you never mention this man again after this. This sickly infatuation dies here," Tomura said sternly. He moved to wipe Izuku's hands that were wet from his crying. "The second condition is you will play a delicate virgin for Chisaki and make sure no one suspects anything else. I'll handle Himiko and ensure she keeps quiet about all of this."

He put the handkerchief away and Izuku nodded sadly.

“And the last condition is that you do not say a word to Bakugou about the role you or Chisaki played in killing his mother.”

Izuku halted.

His eyes widened by several fractions and his heart broke further.

“I know you want to ‘do the right thing’ and be honest, but that’s your defect speaking,” Tomura quickly cut down before Izuku could object. “I can not afford to have you maimed, kidnapped or mangled before the consummation with Chisaki. And I need Chisaki in one piece to give me the transfer of power. If that loose canon blond knew about what both of you did, it would be a pain in my ass. And above all, I do not want you getting hurt. Do you understand?”

Izuku didn’t say anything right away.

The concept of keeping the truth away from Katsuki felt impossible. How was he supposed to look him in his eye knowing he was the one who put a bullet in his mother? How could he kiss him?

But Izuku nodded, taking the extension of kindness Tomura once again showed him.

“I understand, Big Brother,” Izuku whispered. “I won’t say anything about it.”

His words signed an invisible dotted line and the obedience that Tomura installed in him zipped his lips tight.

Tomura nodded his head satisfied with the answer. He plucked a piece of dirt out of Izuku’s hair and flicked it away.

“I’ll be back to collect you in several weeks,” Tomura said. “When I call, be ready to leave within the hour. No questions about it. If you resist, I’ll kill that Bakugou where he stands and put a permanent end to all this foolishness.”

Izuku lowered his eyes. He blankly nodded.

Static as loud as a storm cut through Izuku’s ears as Tomura stood up. He said something, but Izuku didn’t exactly hear it. Tomura walked across the field to the estate. When he came back he had Himiko with him and the stack of red folders in his hands. Both his siblings stood still, looming over him with cold, unmoving gazes. Izuku glanced up at them, and felt terribly small and weak.

Izuku noted how quickly the pedestal of bravery Katsuki placed him on crumbled in the presence of Tomura. So much for standing on his own.

“Get inside and get some rest, Izuku,” Tomura commanded before turning on his heel. “We’ll see you soon enough.”

Himiko gave Izuku a long, wordless stare before following behind Tomura. Izuku watched as they got into Tomura's car and drove off.

When the vehicle was out of sight, Izuku tried to force himself to move. But he couldn't. His body slightly trembled and his stomach was seasick. He stayed where he was in the open field with the autumn wind cutting into him.

He closed his eyes and curled into himself. Everything hurt from the inside out as he fully began to process all the information. The ugly truth bared its teeth: He had killed Katsuki's mother. He stayed in the field with his eyes closed as he went over every scenario to try to tell Katsuki. He searched for the least painful way that would save Katsuki some of the misery—but he found nothing.

There was no way to tell Katsuki without irreversibly hurting him.

When Izuku opened his eyes he flinched.

Sitting staggeringly close to him was the phantom of Hiryu.

His body mirrored Izuku's. His blackened eyes were leaking dark liquid similar to tears. Izuku blinked once and then blinked again wondering if the figment of his imagination would go away.

But it didn't.

It stayed closer than it ever did before and cried dark tears the same as him.

"Tomura might be right," Hiryu's phantom whispered. "If you could kill me, then Katsuki would be able to kill you."

Izuku screwed his eyes shut to block out the taboo thought. But the longer he stayed alone with himself, suddenly all the scenarios of telling Katsuki the truth twisted on each other. Every scene became darker and more distorted as the visions mixed with the gruesome red folders Tomura had shown.

"He could kill you easily," Hiryu's ghost added. The voice split like it was two people speaking, one Hiryu and the other Tomura. "What if he never really liked you? What if it was lust this whole time?"

Izuku choked on a small sob as he tried to will away the dark thoughts. He shook his head and tried to tell himself Katsuki cared for him and Tomura was wrong. They were fated and always held each other's best interest in mind. Even when they didn't know who the other was for eight years, they cared.

That had to mean something, right?

Maybe Katsuki couldn't kill him in the same way Izuku could never kill him. Maybe it was truly fate?

“But what if it wasn’t?” The phantom continued to twist the knife, speaking only in Tomura’s voice now. “What if he only cares about your body like everyone else? Slitting your throat would be nothing to him because you are nothing.”

All the information from the night crammed into Izuku’s brain in one go, tripping and mingling together in a terrible concoction. But worst of all he could see it—he could see Katsuki hurting him. It was easy to imagine after so many years. He knew how Katsuki’s face would contort with the flame of killer instinct in his eyes.

“Katsuki could hurt you,” Tomura’s dark voice echoed in his head. “And he will once he discovers what you did.”

Izuku sobbed softly as he became lost in his mind.



All night Izuku circled the drain in his own personalized version of hell.

He was tormented with distorted voices, visions, and bloodied scenarios of the future. He stayed stuck in the middle of the field of blood colored flowers, imagining himself to be drenched in the same shade of red. He unwillingly imagined Katsuki maiming him over and over while cruelly saying how he could never love someone who killed his mother.

Izuku tried to snap himself out of it, but with every attempt he plunged himself into being further hysterical. It was too much to accept the truth of what he’d done—and each time he thought about the way Bakugou Mitsuki’s body dropped to the cold ground, the more he realized how much he did deserve to be hurt.

The night passed and Izuku didn’t register that the sun had come up. His body shook with exhaustion as he curled into himself, crying softly. He held his head as all his dreams were torn apart limb from limb.

Suddenly, the sound of his name teleported him back to his body.

“Izuku!” Katsuki called.

Izuku violently flinched and whipped his head up.

He turned his bloodshot eyes to see Katsuki standing in the morning glory. Beautiful rays of light shone down on him, making him seem as if he was made of glitter and his perfect red eyes were bright with light.

Izuku averted his gaze quickly, feeling like he didn’t deserve to look upon Katsuki.

Izuku clammed up as Katsuki approached. Guilt as heavy as gravity crashed down on Izuku when Katsuki immediately kneeled down to his level. His worried eyes darted all across Izuku’s figure until they finally landed on his face.

“What happened?” Katsuki asked wearily. “Why are you out here crying?”

Izuku quickly wiped his tears as the voice of Tomura echoed in his head and controlled him.

"Do not say a word to that Bakugou about the role you or Chisaki played in killing his mother."

Izuku's throat slammed shut on command and he felt like heaving. His brows furrowed tightly together in intense tension as he tried to will himself to say the truth—but the hold Tomura held over him was stronger. He flickered his eyes down to Katsuki's bare wedding finger.

Suddenly, all the violent scenarios that his imagination conjured up came rushing back.

One particular one of Katsuki sinking his blade into his neck stood out.

"You would never hurt me…would you?" Izuku asked, barely above a whisper as he tried to push away the gruesome picture.

He wanted to reaffirm his feelings that Katsuki would never hurt him. Maybe this way he could prove to the side of him that heeded Tomura's warnings that there was nothing to fear. It would be safe to tell Katsuki the truth and Tomura's warning wouldn't have as much of a hold on him as it did.

But unfortunately, Katsuki seemed taken back.

His whole body halted movement and he searched Izuku's face.

"Of course, I wouldn't," Katsuki said off-handedly but it wasn't convincing enough for Izuku's cautious side to back down. Katsuki took a closer look at Izuku's ankle, but Izuku gripped him tightly—entirely desperate.

Katsuki frowned and asked, "Where is this coming from?"

"I'm—I'm only wondering," Izuku replied. "The time we spent here meant something for you?"

Katsuki nodded. "It means everything."

"A-And no matter what, you wouldn't—no, couldn't—kill me?" Izuku sobbed.

Katsuki was wearing an expression of shock and disgruntlement. He frowned deeply and nearly seemed offended by what Izuku was suggesting. He helped Izuku wipe away some tears and sighed.

"I would never try to kill you," Katsuki promised.

Izuku's voice was nearly found again after having it so violently snatched away. He tried to say the truth about what he learned, but found himself hindered once more by the obedience in his chest. Dark warning glares from Tomura appeared and he could see his brother shake his head slowly in discouragement.

With the vision of Tomura came the reminder of Katsuki's co-workers.

"B-But what about the kill orders you have on me?" Izuku asked, trying hard to dissolve all the layers stopping him from outright saying the truth.

"Those were only because you butchered Rin Hiyru and kept messing with assignments," Katsuki said a little too flippantly. Now Hiryu's ghost was sitting next to Katsuki reminding Izuku that he pulled the trigger and murdered his own brother. "That shouldn't be surprising. All that is in the past now, I told you I would get the kill order shit straightened up. My ex-colleague is working on clearing it soon when he can."

"He's probably always been wanting to kill you," Hiryu's ghost whispered with Tomura's voice. "Maybe it'll be like ticking a checkbox when he finally hears about what you've done."

Izuku felt deeply sick.

"How long did you have the orders?" Izuku continued to press.

Katsuki pursed his lips to the side, seemingly running out of patience for Izuku's random assortment of questions. "I was ordered to kill you the second I saw you after Madrid."

At that, Izuku became hopeful. He said slowly, "But you never did."

"Because I wasn't trying to blow my goddamn cover with Moore looking at us as hard as he was."

Izuku clammed up again. He withdrew and the side of him that heeded Tomura began to put its shield up.

"So would you have killed me if Moore didn't get involved?" Izuku asked quietly.

Katsuki opened his mouth, then he closed it. He caressed Izuku's shoulders lightly. "Izuku, where is this coming from? You're worrying me. You never answered why you were out here crying in the first place."

"Please, answer the question," Izuku said. His voice splintered entirely as his hold on his sanity slipped.

Katsuki took a deep breath in. He made a cringe face as if it made him pained to admit what he was about to say.

"Yes," Katsuki said and some of Izuku's hope fell out to the bottom of his body. "If we hadn't run into Moore, I would have attempted to kill you. But that's irrelevant because I had been trying to kill you for years. That shouldn't be surprising or a testament to anything."

Izuku nodded in understanding, and the side of him that took Tomura seriously strong-armed the control of his body. His throat officially slammed shut and the truth was not making its way out any time soon.

Katsuki ‘tsk’d under his breath and shuffled in closely to Izuku to hold him with one arm.

“C’mon, Izuku. This is stupid,” Katsuki said, ignorant of the inner battle inside of Izuku’s head. “That’s the past and we’ve always been at odds until recently. But everything is different now and that’s good. So, what if we had crossed some issues in our line of work? I had no clue who you were before.”

“Funny isn’t it?” Hiryu’s ghost cruelly whispered. “Even when you didn’t know it was him you still loved him. But it’s not the same. You’re not special to him the way he is to you.”

The darkened thought made Izuku’s chest tighten.

“I could never kill you, even when I didn’t know,” Izuku whispered, barely audible. “I-I th-thought it might be the same.”

“I’m sorry,” Katsuki whispered and kissed Izuku’s forehead. “I’m really sorry that I can’t say I felt the same when you were only Deku to me—but I can say that now and that’s all that matters. You’re the only person I’ve ever felt this…close to. Shit happens, feelings change. I would never try to kill you again if that’s what you’re worried about. Nothing could change that.”

Izuku looked at Katsuki and asked, “Nothing?”

“Nothing,” Katsuki reassured.

Izuku didn’t believe that was true as he thought about Bakugou Mitsuki. The truth banged its fist at the closed part of his throat and tears welled up inside of Izuku’s eyes. He stared at Katsuki and he wanted to say sorry—but couldn’t.

So instead Izuku hugged him. He tried to translate all the remorse that was burning inside of him as if Katsuki could feel it through his skin.

Katsuki was clearly confused, but he didn’t say anything further. He did as he always did and smiled at Izuku. He ran a hand through Izuku’s messy curls and then stopped. He shifted to plucking out stray leaves and lone higanbana petals that were stuck in Izuku’s thick curls.

“Now that your irrational fears are settled, why were you out here in the middle of the field crying?” Katsuki asked once more. He unhappily dug out more dirt and petals. “A little fucking concerning, don’t you think?”

Izuku thought about Tomura. He smiled sadly.

“It’s nothing to worry about,” Izuku explained quietly. “I tried seeing if I could walk on my own. Looks like I can’t yet.”

ɯɯɯ

As the day went on, Izuku learned guilt was like a rolling tide washing over a rock. With every wave that came over him, a piece of him was withered down and washed away. All he

wanted was to be carried away under the tide and rightfully drown in his sorrows like his guilt told him he deserved.

Katsuki continued about the same like nothing happened. And of course, why wouldn't he? He didn't know the truth. But Izuku found it difficult to look at Katsuki or even be in the same room as him.

Over the course of the next two days, Izuku started to withdraw.

He put space between him and Katsuki because the warnings from Tomura rang in his head like deafening echoes.

He felt stuck. But despite all of that, he knew he would only ever hurt Katsuki if he stayed in his life. Every second he stayed in Katsuki's presence was a true snake-like deception. And Izuku didn't want to continue deceiving Katsuki so he decided he would begin the separation process.

It was time to get back on track to getting the kids out anyways.

On the third day after Tomura's visit, Izuku knew they had to discuss their impending divorce.

It would be the first step in rightfully ridding Katsuki of him and getting back on track to get the kids out.

They were having dinner in the kitchen and Katsuki was making chicken curry on the stove. The savory smell beckoned to Izuku but the emptiness in his chest was stronger. He had no urge to eat as he stared down in his lap in deep thought.

The radio was playing in the background and a subject caught Izuku's attention.

"We are interviewing a survivor from the Okinawa human trafficking tragedy. She is speaking out," the voice of a news reporter announced. Both Izuku and Katsuki sharply cut their eyes towards the tiny device. "Now tell us, what did you see again? This seems to conflict with the original police reports."

"There was a man in all black with blood-colored eyes," the wobbly voice of the witness whispered. "His eyes nearly glowed in the dark—and he moved so fluidly through all the rooms. He saved us from those monsters, like an angel of death reaping all of their souls."

Katsuki pressed his lips in a thin line and Izuku frowned at the description.

Angel of Death?

He cut his eyes over to Katsuki and felt a chill run up his arms.

"Do you think this could potentially be the work of the mysterious Scarlet Eyed Killer?" The reporter probed. "The description of his eyes combined with the amount of blood shed matches—"

Katsuki quickly turned the radio off.

“Sorry,” Katsuki grumbled and went back to cooking. “I don’t exactly feel like reliving that. I still get fucking hives thinking about the cages and red rooms. Plus, I don’t really want to hear if I have another goddamn nickname. First The Scarlet Eyed Killer, now The Angel of Death? It’s too much.”

Izuku didn’t have quite the right response.

He contemplated a little too long on Katsuki’s violent side and wordlessly looked back down towards his lap. It was here that he caught sight of the scar on his palm that he received from Katsuki.

He traced it slowly, realizing that the scar was from the same night Izuku killed Katsuki’s mother.

It was proof Katsuki had both kindness and violence inside of him. They bloomed together, intertwining like growing vines covering the depths inside of his soul. It had been such a split second decision and showed how fast Katsuki could go from killer to savior.

Izuku wondered if Katsuki hadn’t shown him kindness that night, would Mitsuki still be alive? The answer was likely no. Realistically, another viper would’ve gone back and finished the job. Chisaki wasn’t a fan of loose ends.

But why did it have to be him who did it in the end?

“Because you’re not destined to be together,” the distorted voice of Tomura whispered.

Izuku lowered his head further and dug his fingers into his scar. He reasoned they were always bound to go their separate ways after this. This makeshift honeymoon wasn’t supposed to be a permanent fixture and they needed to face reality.

“Katsuki,” Izuku whispered without glancing up. He braced himself to say words he never wanted to. “We should get the divorce this week.”

Several beats of silence passed.

Izuku frowned at the lack of response and finally lifted his gaze. He saw Katsuki stirring the pot with no sign of acknowledgement of what he said.

“Katsuki. Did you hear me?” Izuku asked gently.

“I heard you,” Katsuki mumbled.

“…And?”

Katsuki sucked in a deep breath. He clicked off the stove and turned around with a determined stare.

“And I don’t want a divorce.”

Had this been a week ago, Izuku would have probably been thrilled yet terrified. He would have known it wasn't realistic but would have found a way to make it work. But now Izuku was stone cold sober, off cloud nine, and thinking pragmatically. But he was more surprised that Katsuki wasn't.

He looked at Katsuki sideways. "Wh-What? We can't stay married—"

"Why not? We like each other. *A lot.* We get along fucking splendidly or whatever the hell it's called. Why would we get divorced?"

Izuku stared at Katsuki and Katsuki glared right back at him. It quickly dawned upon Izuku that this was going to be an argument. He folded his arms to steady his nerves because he knew Katsuki was an immovable object.

"So, what's your plan?" Izuku muttered, slightly agitated that this wasn't going the way he thought. "We secretly date in between my assignments and build up to justifying being legally married?"

Because that's what Izuku's plan had been.

"My plan is you don't have any more assignments," Katsuki corrected.

All thoughts inside of Izuku came to a screeching halt. He stared at Katsuki like he'd gone mad because that was an insane, absolute solution. Katsuki really assumed he could simply leave his life as a viper? Vipers didn't get to stop working. They either died or they ran away and then died. There was no such thing as retirement.

Katsuki walked towards him, pulled a chair out and sat down at eye level with him. Izuku's heart thumped with love at the way Katsuki was looking at him. It was so soft and gentle and Izuku knew he didn't deserve any of it.

"Izuku. I want you to stay here with me," Katsuki said firmly.

He grasped Izuku's hands, and it transported Izuku far back to that year in Tokyo.

For a moment it felt like they were both seven again, hopelessly holding onto a false marriage that would not pan out in the real world. Izuku wanted to say what he said back then, but as the murder of Bakugou Mitsuki sat on his heart, Izuku knew there was only one answer.

"I have to leave, Katsuki," Izuku whispered. "I can't stay with you."

A piece of him broke seeing how Katsuki's face crumbled.

"But you shouldn't go back to that place," Katsuki tried to reason. His grip on Izuku's hands grew tighter, the same way they had that day in the nook. "Don't you like it here with me?"

"Of course I like it here but you're not making sense."

“No. *You’re* not making sense,” Katsuki snapped. “You have an out, Izuku. Why go back to a place where you’re fucking abused? You could stay here, and we could figure out a way to keep you away from people who would track you down. Look. I asked my supervisor about disappearance help—”

“—I don’t get to disappear, Katsuki,” Izuku cut off. He pulled his hands out of Katsuki’s and shook his head. “My life isn’t simple like that and going through some disappearance program won’t work for me.”

“Well, we can make it fucking work. How do you know if you don’t try? Hah? At least give it a shot.”

Izuku’s eyes welled up. This fantasy they were stuck in was truly torture of what would never be.

Izuku shook his head fast. “No. Katsuki, stop. That isn’t realistic—”

“—*Realistic*?” Katsuki huffed, frustrated. He leaned away from Izuku in disbelief. “Staying somewhere where you’re *free* versus a place you were fucking *sold* to isn’t *realistic*?”

Izuku gritted his teeth to keep from crying. “No. It’s not.”

“Y’know what—if we’re going to rip the reality Band-Aid off, *let’s*.”

Izuku’s heart thumped as Katsuki’s dangerous eyes locked onto him. Sitting inside of them was a violence that hadn’t been directed towards him in months. It made him still and then pause as visions of Katsuki hurting him flickered in the back of his mind.

Katsuki leaned menacingly into Izuku’s face, and they locked in unmoving stares. Katsuki curled his upper lip as he spat his next words.

“I’m not allowing you to go back to somewhere that forces you to kill.” Katsuki glowered. “I will triple deadbolt all these doors and break your limbs before I allow you to go back to somewhere like that, Izuku. And I fucking *mean it*.”

At that, Izuku became uneasy.

He leaned back a bit, realizing Katsuki’s eyes translated that he was telling the truth. Not an ounce of a lie or over exaggeration was there. Katsuki had full intentions of breaking his arm and legs if he made a move to leave.

“Especially when you should have been with *me*,” Katsuki continued. “You should’ve—You should’ve been with me all this time. Me leaving Tokyo was a mistake and we can correct it now. Why else would we have come across each other again all these years? It’s—”

Fate.

Izuku waited for Katsuki to say that word yet again.

He waited and waited, and maybe if he heard it he would believe they were truly fated if the other half of him did too. But the word never came because Katsuki didn't believe in fate and Izuku was beginning to question if he believed in it anymore either. Because if fate was him killing the mother of the only man he ever loved, then maybe Izuku had fate all wrong.

Maybe Katsuki was right in the end. There was no such thing as fate, only consequences.

"But you *did* leave Tokyo, and I *didn't*. That's reality," Izuku whispered. He looked down at his hands and traced that scar on his palm again. "We can't correct how we branched into different paths. No matter how much I wish we could, we can't and I'm pushing my *limit*, Katsuki. My time is basically up. I borrowed all the favors I could to stay here for as long as I can, but I *can't* stay any longer and we can't stay married."

Izuku's voice was pained beyond his years as he tried his best to push Katsuki away.

"Who the fuck do I have to kill if you need to get out?" Katsuki begged viciously. "That big brother? Your supervisor? The fucking *Governor*? I don't give a damn how many throats I have to slit if it means you don't go back to the place that you were trafficked to. Do you hear how insane that sounds?! You want to stay here, don't you?"

Izuku flinched at the mention of Tomura. A lifetime of beating made him turn his head away from Katsuki.

"Nothing in my life is about what I want," Izuku said solidly to remind himself exactly what he was.

"But if it was—you would want to stay here with me, wouldn't you?"

"Of course, I would."

"Exactly. You like it here. You want this type of life as badly as I do, and we fit together so fucking well."

Katsuki gently took Izuku's chin and turned his face so they could see each other. Izuku's wall was crumbling, and his emotions were beginning to be laid bare. He finally dared to look into Katsuki's eyes and all he saw was Mitsuki.

"You're more than a passing moment in my life and you know I'm more than that to you," Katsuki whispered and gently stroked Izuku's chin with his thumb. "These last few months were proof of how our lives should be—we should be together; we always should've been, and I don't want to let you go."

He cusped Izuku's face with both hands and held eye contact. Izuku's heart hurt as Katsuki wordlessly pleaded so deeply for him to give in to temptation once more.

"Please, Izuku. Stay with me this time," Katsuki begged.

And those were the words that broke him.

Izuku was pulled in every direction by different, intense feelings. On one end was Tomura. Another Chisaki. He even felt the strong hold of Hiryu and the cold grasp of Mitsuki. The most painful pull was Katsuki, tugging on his heart strings while everyone else was grabbing at his skin.

But worst of all, Izuku felt Katsuma holding on to him.

His face crumbled. He sobbed and lifted his trembling hands up to Katsuki's. He grasped Katsuki's wrists and slowly lowered their hands down onto his lap. He wished things were different but he had to leave for the better of everyone involved.

"I can't stay because there are kids," Izuku confessed.

He pulled that card and held it up in hopes that this would make the separation easier.

He never got around to telling Katsuki about the issue of the new cohort—and he secretly hoped he never had to. He knew that with Katsuki's passionate protectiveness, Katsuki would want to help. And one of Izuku's fears was anchoring Katsuki into the same pits of hell he was trapped in.

But maybe if he knew Izuku needed to leave to help others, then he would let him walk out that door without a fight.

"…What?" Katsuki whispered.

His eyes widened and Izuku could see his perspective did as well.

"A-At my home, in Tokyo—there's *kids*." Izuku tried to stop his tears and clenched his jaw. "I can't leave them there alone, Katsuki. I can't. I have one I'm supposed to watch over. I'm his big brother like my big brother is to me. His name is Katsuma and he's so soft. I can't leave him there to be broken and hurt. Or worse, killed."

"Have you been trying to get them out?" Katsuki asked, suddenly very sober on reality.

"Of course I have," Izuku said. "I could never forgive myself if I let them do what they did to me to them. I can't fix what occurred, but I can prevent it from happening again."

"Then let me help," Katsuki easily offered, but that wasn't what Izuku hoped he say. "I have the information of someone named Nana who might be able to get us a lead on what to do." And with every word Katsuki spoke, Izuku felt his patience grow thinner and thinner. Why wasn't this easier? "I can go back with you to Tokyo, and we can do it together and then we can—"

"No!" Izuku snapped angrily and tore himself away from Katsuki. "Just fucking stop!"

Katsuki slammed his fist on the table. "Are you serious?! Why are you so damn insistent on us being separated again?!"

"Because you're out!" Izuku's voice boomed on all the walls.

Katsuki was stunned speechless at the sheer volume that erupted from Izuku.

“You’re finally out, why would I drag you back in with my own mess?!” Izuku continued with a heavy heart. “Don’t you get it? This is why I have been trying to help you get set up. You’re done! You’re free! You can start all the way over! You deserve to be normal—at least that way one of us can be!”

Izuku’s chest heaved as he caught his breath.

His lips pulled back as he curled his fists. Guilt for ruining Katsuki’s life began to rot him from the inside out. He couldn’t accept Katsuki’s help now. Not after finding out he was the one responsible for making Katsuki an orphan.

“I’ll never be normal,” Izuku admitted gravely. “There is no contract or number of years for me to be released. This is who I am and between the two of us, only one of us is a real sinner and it’s not you. I have done t-terrible things, Katsuki. Shit I can’t undo no matter how much I wish I could and because of that, I cannot stay here. I want to do right for you, Katsuki and I’m not right for you.”

“You can’t decide what’s right for me—”

“—Believe me on this one,” Izuku whispered. “We’re not meant to be together.”

Izuku would never say out loud how much that hurt him to admit.

Katsuki didn’t say anything back.

Instead, he curled his fists and his frown hardened to the point Izuku saw new frown lines crease into his skin. Katsuki didn’t blink. He didn’t move. His eyes stayed sharply homed in on Izuku, and Izuku wondered what was going through his head as he showed no signs of emotions further.

The kettle on the stove top went off, reminding Izuku there was tea going. It whistled shrilly in their uncomfortable silence.

“You don’t mean that,” Katsuki hissed. “And you’re not fucking going back alone if I can help it. If you leave out of here without me, I am going to be right behind you whether you like it or not.” He stood up angrily and went back over to the stove to prepare two plates. “This conversation is done and we’re not getting a divorce.”

Izuku angrily wiped his tears away.

There was no point in responding. Katsuki was too stubborn and there was no way for him to see that this was the right move like they agreed to in the first place. It was here that Izuku realized the only way he would likely leave with his bones in tack was by catching Katsuki off guard.

Izuku watched as Katsuki walked back over to the dining table and unceremoniously shoved him his plate of curry and took a seat again.

They ate in silence and barely looked at each other.



Fourth Month of Honeymoon

Over the next few days Izuku tried to find ways to come out with the truth.

He tried practicing it in the mirror and even went over how to deliver it in his head. He tried to push past the part of him that was scared of Katsuki lashing out. But it was like coming in contact with a steel, Tomura shaped wall.

Every time he tried to tell Katsuki the truth face to face, all he saw was Tomura and those red folders.

Izuku kept his distance because of that and found himself reading again. It made him sad a bit, now that he understood this was his coping mechanism. But as he looked at the words on the page, he came across an idea: he could write the truth in a letter.

And technically—that wouldn't be *saying* anything. It was a tiny loophole in what Tomura instructed and the idea of writing the truth was easier than speaking it.

Izuku tried to write over the next day or so. He tried and tried to scribble the words in his notebook but nothing felt right. The first version felt too self-pitying. The second came across too emotionless. He ripped out pages from his notebook repeatedly, and began to grow angry with himself that he didn't know how to properly capture what he wanted to say.

The night after his fifth attempt at writing, Izuku tossed and turned.

He was unable to go to sleep as visions of Mitsuki's bloodied body haunted him. Izuku looked over at Katsuki who was sound asleep and decided to lock himself in the bathroom. He had stashed his notebook in there earlier so he could write without interruption. He quietly tried to scribble more words but was still unsatisfied with every sentence.

In a fit of frustration, he threw the notebook against the wall. He sobbed as he pushed the heels of his palms into his eyes and curled into himself on the ground.

"Wh-Why did it have to be this way?" Izuku sobbed angrily. "I don't understand. I don't want it to be like th-this."

But it was, and he needed to come to terms with it one way or another.



In the morning, Katsuki seemed sad. They hadn't cuddled since the fight and had been sleeping butt to butt in awkward silence. Usually Izuku got out of bed before Katsuki would say anything, but this time Katsuki turned over and lightly rubbed Izuku's shoulder.

"Good morning," Katsuki said quietly.

Izuku turned over and his heart clenched at how dejected Katsuki seemed. Izuku now felt guilty for causing Katsuki distress with his emotional withdrawal.

“Good morning, Kacchan,” Izuku said quietly. “Did you, um, sleep okay?”

“No,” Katsuki answered honestly.

Izuku didn’t either. He pressed his lip in a thin line and resisted the urge to say sorry. Katsuki then leaned forward and wrapped his arm around him. He kissed Izuku’s temple and rested his head against him.

“Look. I know you’re still upset from our fight, but how about we go somewhere together later today?” Katsuki suggested. “I would really like it if we went back to normal. I don’t think I like us being mad at each other like this.”

Izuku didn’t either. He knew that there was no way to go all the way back to the way they were, but Izuku didn’t want to give Katsuki anymore grief and pain.

“Okay,” Izuku agreed. “I-I don’t like us being mad at each other either.”

They smiled quietly at one another.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When they got dressed and ready to leave, Katsuki was strangely calm. He was giving Izuku a quiet smile as he tied up his fall boots.

“Where are we going?” Izuku asked as he pulled on his fall jacket.

“You’ll see when we get there,” Katsuki explained, mumbling under his breath a bit. He smiled at Izuku and pulled on his leather jacket. “Are you ready to get going?”

Izuku nodded and grabbed his crutches. He needed to use them again to stabilize himself after finding sharp pain radiating up his leg. He assumed it was a minor setback after the encounter with both Tomura and whoever Katsuki’s coworker was.

Izuku began to hop on his crutches towards the door. Right when he was about to leave for outside, Katsuki stopped him. He squatted low as a signal for Izuku to get on his back. Izuku felt hesitant, still feeling the looming sensation of guilt crawling all over his bones.

But one look from Katsuki made Izuku climb on.

They walked outside into the higanbana field together. Izuku quietly rested his tired head against Katsuki’s, and wrapped his arms and legs tightly around him. It was still dark outside and before sunrise. Everything was silent in the gentle darkness as they traveled through the field of flowers towards the back of the estate.

Awaiting them at the edge of the field was a dense row of trees. Izuku thought maybe they would take a turn towards the road, but instead Katsuki stepped right into the forest.

Izuku was quiet and Katsuki was too. The howling wind blew through their hair when they were fully engulfed in the shadows. Above them were trees shaded in vibrant reds from the turning of seasons.

As they walked further in, Izuku felt Katsuki grow tensor with every step. His shoulders locked up and his heart rate skyrocketed. Izuku's attention was officially piqued when they found a stone pathway in the forest. They followed it all the way to a bridge that passed over a tiny stream. The echoing of the morning birds and running water were the only sound as they trekked deeper in the scarlet forestry.

"What is this place?" Izuku asked quietly.

"It's…better to show you."

The stones turned to an unkept, white marble path that looked as if it hadn't been tended to in years. The crunch of Katsuki's feet on the leaves under his boot pierced the silence.

When they arrived at the clearing, it was chilling. Izuku's breath caught at the sight.

Endless rows and rows of tombstones were neatly aligned with green moss overrunning them. Higanbana flowers naturally grew here too, making the dirt floor of the forest seem like it was painted red. In the back were the older tombs, reaching towards the sky as if they were alive and pointing to the deities in the questionable heavens. Those held the most moss covering them, swallowing whoever's name was written.

Then gradually as the rows pushed further and further to the front, newer tombs could be easily distinguished. They were a deep gray. Spots of stone peaked from underneath the thick green and on the tombs were names that faded away from the harshness of nature through the years.

In the utmost front row were three tombs. The newest ones.

Izuku could feel the eyes of ghosts looking straight into his soul.

Katsuki took a deep breath in. The wind cut through them again, and Izuku glanced above to stare at the strangely enchanting sight of thick vines hanging down from the treetops. The vines spread all around like veins, reaching and connecting every tomb.

Katsuki walked up to one grave and grew quiet.

The subtle etching of the name 'Mitsuki' was faintly visible.

Izuku's eyes went wide and his stomach dropped.

"This—This is…" The words trailed off, but he didn't need to finish.

"Yes. It. I…I moved her here when I found this place," Katsuki confessed. "It felt right to reunite them after they had spent a lifetime apart. Maybe they are finally making amends on the other side, or at least that's what I tell myself to feel better. Who knows if this was the right thing to do?"

Izuku hugged Katsuki tightly.

This felt wrong on many levels. He shouldn't be here, much less looking at her grave. He was trespassing on the sanctity of grounds like this.

Carefully, Katsuki let Izuku down. They both sat on the thick forest floor as the red leaves swayed above them. Izuku stared at Mitsuki's grave stone and saw how there was a tiny detail of carnations engraved into the stone. That small drawing made Izuku realize how good Katsuki was deep down. His heart was too pure for this world really, even despite his violent tendencies.

Izuku turned to Katsuki and smiled sadly.

"You did the right thing," Izuku said quietly. "You have a good heart, Kacchan."

"I hope I do," Katsuki muttered, unsure. "This is the only place I didn't have the real strength to come back to, more than the nursery. I feel guilty sometimes, living in that house and not paying my respects to the people who left it here for me."

Katsuki turned his eyes to the other two tombstones next to his mother. Izuku saw the names 'Ren' and 'Hina' were fainter than 'Mitsuki'.

"Do you ever wonder what they were like?" Izuku asked.

"All the time." Katsuki smiled a little. "I try to pick out which parts of my mother's personality belonged to who and it—it makes her feel complete."

Izuku lowered his head, paying respect. He remembered the way Katsuki's mother was smiling and eating popcorn on her couch and then the lovely way she was singing and cleaning right before he pulled the trigger.

A pain too large to describe took a hold of Izuku as he asked, "…What was she like?"

"She was a hurricane," Katsuki grumbled fondly. A lopsided smirk bloomed on his face. "Funny. Risk taker. Energetic. Secretive. Loud. Irresponsible. Caring in her own way."

Katsuki seemed to carry many of her traits.

"She sounds like she was nice." Izuku whispered. "I can tell you loved her a lot."

"I did, but I also resented her too," Katsuki admitted. "You know that type of resentment you feel guilty for, but it sits inside of you anyways. I used to ignore it all the time because I never want to hate her but…I think I'm finally accepting that two truths can exist at once. I loved her fiercely. But I resented her quietly."

The wind blew between them, shaking the leaves and swaying the vines above their heads.

"I…I brought you here because this is the last part of me, Izuku."

Katsuki turned inwards towards him and there was fountains of guilt pooling out of Izuku. It tripled and the waves grew larger and larger until Izuku could no longer keep his head above the water.

Katsuki took Izuku's hand in his and gripped it tightly as he continued speaking.

"There's nothing more I think I can show you or tell you. You have all of me and this is the most vulnerable I've ever been with anyone. I know you don't like to talk about yourself a lot —and I can respect that because it is easy to see certain things hurt you to think about. But I want you to see all of me because I trust you—entirely."

Izuku sadly smiled as another wave of guilt rocked him.

He tried to say the words of the truth but he couldn't. He couldn't bear to hurt Katsuki here, where his mother spirit rested. Instead Izuku embraced him and buried his face into his neck. His hands threaded through Katsuki's hair and he held back tears.

"Thank you for trusting me enough to bring me here," Izuku whispered. "I trust you too."

ᔓᔓᔓ

A large bit of Izuku's anxiety was buried after that. Katsuki trusted him, and Izuku trusted him too. This proved Katsuki would never hurt him no matter what Tomura insisted. As the sun rose, Katsuki said he wanted to check if something was still in the back of the graveyard.

He quickly walked away, and left Izuku alone in front of the grave of Mitsuki.

Izuku stared at the grave and without much effort, he imagined Mitsuki in front of him smirking in the same way Katsuki always did.

She was beautiful.

"I'm sorry," Izuku quietly confessed. He lowered his head and plucked four flowers from beside him. He tied them together with a small vine to create a makeshift bouquet. "I'm so sorry for what I did. I'll do everything I can to make it up to you and your son."

He placed the tiny bouquet on the grave and bowed his head all the way to the ground.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When Katsuki came back, he gathered Izuku and led them to the back of the gravesite.

The Bakugous who lived here before them clearly cherished their family lineage. Katsuki's ancestors made the family grave site something extraordinary. They made death seem peaceful and like it was a work of art instead of something gloomy and morbid.

A small lake was found the further into the grave site they went, and there was an all-white gazebo poised like a lone soldier who survived years of grief by itself. It was overrun with

vines and dusted with red leaves. It was perfectly stationed next to the lake, giving a sanctuary to rest.

Katsuki wandered near it, and they sat inside. Wordlessly, the two of them watched the sunrise together. It wasn't the first sunrise they witnessed with the other, but this one was different. The rosy dusk bled up from the ground and into the water. It spread all over like harmless fire, covering everything in its warmth.

Both of them stared quietly.

Izuku studied their reflections in the water. He stared and stared as if they would shape shift into two people who might have a shot of being together. Then as the sun rose fully, a part of Izuku melted. He and Katsuki began to talk about the future, and what it would be like to live in different lifetimes together.

Katsuki's brilliant grin rivaled the sun behind him as they talked. In this elegant moment, Izuku could picture a million lifetimes with Katsuki. He knew they must've had great ones before this, and how beautiful their love must have been to stretch through different universes over and over again. Izuku hoped that when their next lifetime came around, it would be better and more gentle than this one.

Katsuki turned his body towards Izuku, and he took his hand. Then Katsuki dropped three words that would forever change the shape of Izuku's soul.

"I love you, Izuku," Katsuki confessed.

Izuku's eyes softened, and his tears poured down. His heart soared higher than ever, and he could feel the part of him that ever doubted how Katsuki cared for him fade away.

"I love you too, Katsuki," Izuku confessed back.

The weight on his chest lifted and released him. Everything clicked together as he looked at Katsuki in that ethereal moment. They were truly two souls crafted from the same tragic substance and their lives were so smoothly connected in every way.

Izuku understood now; In both love and pain, they were one.

After exchanging 'I love yous', Izuku found peace.

The side of him that was made doubtful by Tomura into believing Katsuki didn't care for him was vanquished. It was slain with the glimmering sword of Katsuki's love and Izuku never felt more cared for in his life. But because of that, it was the exact reason he couldn't stay in Katsuki's life.

He felt secure enough to let Katsuki know the truth through writing. When they got home later that night, Izuku found the words to put into a letter as if Katsuki's kiss breathed them into him.

That night in the bathroom, Izuku poured his heart into writing his goodbye letter.

He wrote down everything and left out no detail. From start to finish he detailed what happened the day of The Incident. Izuku took full responsibility for his role in it all and promised to kill Chisaki for both Katsuki and Mitsuki. Izuku even detailed the deal that was on the table regarding his so-called ‘virginity’ and how he would use that to get close to Chisaki. He would easily find a slow but steady way to kill him.

He wrote about how he would send signed divorce papers to the estate when he could. He apologized in a million different ways.

As Izuku finished writing the lengthy apology letter, he hesitated on the last line. His hand shook as he thought about doing something that would either damn him or truly give Katsuki peace.

Izuku wrote down his cell phone number.

If Katsuki needed more closure after reading this, Izuku knew he owed him that much.

When he finished, the letter was ten pages long and covered in tears. Some blotches of blue ink bled with the wetness on the paper, making some words run like a watercolor painting. Izuku shakily folded up all the pages and tucked them neatly in an envelope.

He wrote ‘To: Katsuki. From: Izuku. The truth about your mother and why I needed to leave’ on it and sealed it shut.



After that, they went back to normal.

Izuku was able to accept his sin and take it in stride. He told himself he owed Katsuki happiness in his last few weeks with him and not to burden him any further. So Izuku smiled, he laughed, they were intimate and Izuku made sure to bring his husband all the joy in the world as a form of repentance.

The first week after their love confessions, they traveled around like they used to.

Katsuki happily gave him piggy back rides everywhere and Izuku peppered kisses all along Katsuki’s cheekbones. They finished trying all the various cuisines they set out to taste and every dinner was romantic as could be.

“You should come back to these,” Izuku said happily. He smiled across at his husband at the candle lit table in the Thai restaurant. “They’re so good!”

It made Izuku’s heart sing with joy when Katsuki taped the list of their favorite restaurants to the fridge the next day.

The second week after their love confessions, Katsuki composed his very first song.

Katsuki had been in classes for a while now, and he wanted to give it a shot. What he wrote was a violin solo that was somehow soft yet sharp. Mysterious yet vulnerable. When Izuku played it for Katsuki it felt like his husband somehow captured the real essence of what the word ‘juxtaposition’ meant. Izuku wondered what inspired it.

“You’re going to make the most beautiful songs,” Izuku said when he finished playing. “I can’t wait to hear what you create.”

He smiled thinking about the music-filled future Katsuki would have. Izuku had no doubts he would hear his husband’s songs being played in some lavish concert hall.

After that, Katsuki began to construct a series of violin solos.

The third week after their love confessions, they watched a string of Izuku’s favorite romance movies.

They snuggled up on the couch every night and Izuku showed Katsuki all the reasons why these particular films he adored more than others. He analyzed the movies down to the very last montage, saying that nothing was done at random. He did this because he could see Katsuki’s eyes twinkle whenever he talked about his own passions. He figured he could afford Katsuki one last happy moment like this.

The fourth week after their confessions, Izuku helped him plant a bundle of pink carnations in the backyard.

After learning pink carnations were Mitsuki’s favorite, Izuku found that it would be a good sign of respect to plant some. They put a bundle next to the garden, but still far away enough from the house that it wasn’t always such a painful reminder. For this, Katsuki expressed gratitude.

He lovingly hugged Izuku and told him thank you.

ɯɯɯ

Last Day of Honeymoon

When Tomura’s call came, Izuku was reading on the porch with the pitter patter of rain to keep him company. The ringtone usually gave Izuku a jolt of anxiety, but this time it was the saddest hymn he ever heard. Izuku slowly closed his book and answered the call with a heavy heart.

“Hello?” Izuku whispered.

“It’s time,” Tomura said calmly. “Be ready to leave in an hour.”

Izuku looked out at the rain clouds. “Okay.”

Tomura hung up and Izuku slid his phone in his pocket. He placed his book down slowly as his fingers began to tremble ever so slightly. He hunched forward in the wooden rocking

chair and his eyes glazed over with raw emotion. He took one last look at the beautiful garden in the middle of the estate and said his quiet goodbyes to it.

With patience, he unwrapped his cast and finally removed it. The air against his skin was rejuvenating. He was fully healed.

Izuku tested walking and he was given no trouble. He rolled his ankle experimentally and was mildly disappointed how quickly time passed. It didn't feel like enough—but Izuku knew it never would be. The only amount of time with Katsuki that would truly be satisfactory would be forever.

Izuku walked back inside, leaving the book on the porch as he began to make his way to the bathroom. He pulled a blank mask of emotions for what he needed to do. He opened the medicine cabinet and pulled out his special cherry chapstick.

It was laced with a small, harmless chemical that Izuku himself was immune to.

Three years ago, Ibarra made this chapstick for him to use on his seduction and kill missions. In theory, a simple kiss and his target would be knocked out. But Izuku never used it because he had no desire to kiss and kill.

Now, he was going to have to use it for the very first time on Katsuki.

Part of Izuku didn't want to. But he knew walking out that door with Katsuki awake would be impossible. Katsuki kept his promises, and he would break Izuku's bones if he tried to leave here without him. And if Tomura arrived in a struggle like that, Katsuki would be six feet deep in the graveyard with the rest of his bloodline within the minute.

Izuku breathed in slowly as he coated his lips in the poisonous gloss.

He straightened his shoulders like a soldier and wandered back into their bedroom. Katsuki was sitting on the bed politely, flipping through the black folder he had brought back from his old headquarters.

Izuku's heart rate jumped to a new high when Katsuki smiled at him. Like always.

"Did you enjoy reading your book?" Katsuki asked gently.

He put the black folder on the nightstand to give Izuku all his attention. Izuku's eyes flickered to the black folder and then back to Katsuki with a loving smile.

Izuku nodded sweetly. "I did. The rain really made me feel like I was in the atmosphere. Only thing that would have made it better was if you read it to me, Kacchan."

"I can read a chapter to you tonight, if you really want." Katsuki smiled back at him and Izuku's heart clutched. "I'm happy you're enjoying all those novels. They were super hard to find, turns out you're not the only nerd fighting to read those sappy books."

Izuku climbed in the bed and snuggled closely to his husband one last time. "Thank you again for finding those for me."

Katsuki snaked an arm around Izuku's waist. "Of course. Anything for you, darling."

Izuku's eyes flickered with deep longing at the mention of 'darling'. He realized then he would never hear such a sweet name from his love's lips again. Izuku smiled gentler and his eyes became shinier in the dim, bedroom light. His hand pushed forward, touching Katsuki's cheek bone. He grazed it so lightly, trying to memorize the shape of him.

Katsuki turned his body inwards and smiled lovingly with half hooded eyes.

Izuku then cupped Katsuki's cheek and leaned their foreheads together.

"I love you so much," Izuku whispered rawly.

"I love you too, darling," Katsuki muttered back.

Katsuki pulled Izuku close to him and both of their eyes naturally closed. The pounding in Izuku's chest hammered until his limbs ached as he relished in their last embrace.

He tried to memorize everything. He took a deep breath in and the sweet smell of cinnamon filled his lungs. He brushed Katsuki's soft blond hair backwards and loved the way his skin was warm. His husband always ran hot. The firm arms encircling him were gentle in a way Izuku knew he would crave for the rest of his life.

Then Katsuki leaned in.

Izuku closed his eyes as his husband kissed him softly.

It was time.

Izuku kissed him back slowly.

Katsuki opened his mouth and tilted Izuku's head when he tasted the sweetness of his chapstick. Izuku steadied himself and pushed into the kiss. His shaking hands gripped Katsuki's shirt and Katsuki was swept under the feeling of their union. Katsuki bit at Izuku's bottom lip and his tongue swiped at the inside of his mouth as if he was trying to get a better taste. Izuku's heart became heavy as he shifted from holding Katsuki's shirt to cradling him.

They broke apart and Izuku sadly smiled at his soon to be ex-husband.

Izuku watched with a broken heart as Katsuki's face went from loving to confused. He swayed slightly and his cheeks became warmer. He blinked progressively slower and slower until his head lulled with its weight.

"Iz—" Katsuki's eyes widened when his tongue was heavy. He grasped urgently at Izuku's shirt; fist tight. "Iz-Izuku—"

Izuku held Katsuki's hand.

Tears now steadily streamed out of Izuku's beautiful green eyes and they dropped directly onto Katsuki. Izuku broke down as he watched Katsuki try to say the words "don't cry" in

broken syllables.

Even now, Katsuki still loves him so purely and fully. Izuku held him as Katsuki's grip on him went slack and his arms dropped to the mattress like a lifeless doll.

"My time is up." Izuku's voice cracked. "I'm sorry, Kacchan. I love you so much."

A lone tear escaped out of Katsuki's eye as he slowly slipped into an unconscious state. He went completely still and the heaviness of his weight dragged Izuku down to lay on the bed. Izuku wiped away the tear from Katsuki's cheek and broke down fully. He cried into Katsuki's chest as he clung to him.

All the waves of guilt dragged him under as he clutched the man who would soon no longer be his husband. He wanted to thank Katsuki for allowing him to know who he was past the layers of their reality and who he might've been with him. That was a gift he could never hold or even quantify.

Maybe in the next life they could be happy.

ɯɯɯ

When he finished crying and gathered himself, Izuku packed up all his belongings. He wiped his face and put on his emotional armor. Right as he was packing his last sweater, he looked at the nightstand where the black folder was. Katsuki mentioned this several times, it was supposed to be a way out for people who were in desperate need of disappearing.

Curiosity prickled at him as he looked at it.

Izuku checked his phone. There were a few more minutes until Tomura arrived.

He walked over to the black folder and opened it.

Immediately, Izuku didn't understand the scribbles inside. It was a cluster of sticky notes, tabs, papers and photographs of people who he'd never seen. There was an old black and white picture of a woman with black hair and dark eyes. Attached to her photo was a yellow sticky note that read 'Nana?' in Katsuki's hand writing in red ink.

Izuku flipped through the papers some more and his eyes widened with each piece he put together. Katsuki was right about this. People could use this to disappear and get far *far* away from whatever danger was chasing them.

He then read one fine printed detail that said Nana was able to help ten people at a time. She couldn't take on more than that because of the time constraints and the effort it took to forge legal documents. An idea clicked together in Izuku's head reading that.

He glanced at Katsuki on the bed sadly. Izuku sighed and kissed Katsuki's forehead.

He really was an angel.

“I’m sorry,” Izuku whispered against Katsuki’s warm skin. “I know you wanted to use this on me, but it would help someone else who deserves it more.”

Izuku closed the black folder and proceeded to pack it in his suitcase.

He could use this for the kids and their families. He had always been thinking in the back of his mind what would happen after he delivered the kids back home and how safe would their families really be. The kids were old enough to talk about what they were raised in. And as far as The Academy was concerned, five was old enough to be killed for talking.

But *this*—if he found Nana and gave her the information on the kids and their families—they could all go on and lead safe, happy lives.

Izuku pressed his lips in a thin line and took one last look at Katsuki. His hands trembled as he placed the envelope of his letter between Katsuki’s fingers.

He neatly folded Katsuki’s hands over it and gave Katsuki’s cheek one last goodbye kiss.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku waited on the porch with his luggage for Tomura to arrive. He held his head down as the rain poured heavier with each passing moment. When the sound of a vehicle approaching reached him, Izuku lifted his head.

He saw Tomura’s luxury black car park close to the gates of the estate. His brother stepped out wearing all black and holding up a black umbrella. In the passenger seat Izuku could see Himiko sitting inside with her arms folded. She sported sunglasses on her expressionless face.

Tomura walked up to the gate and Izuku picked up his bags. He walked out of the gates and Tomura took one of his bags without saying a word. They loaded up the car and closed the trunk with a heavy thud.

Izuku stared blankly at the trunk. He felt strange, like this wasn’t really happening. Or he wasn’t really here. A warm hand slid over his shoulder and Izuku turned to see Tomura gazing at him with genuine pity.

“This is for the best,” Tomura said.

Izuku nodded quietly. He looked over at the estate and felt like he wasn’t finished yet.

“Can…Can I take one last look around?” Izuku whispered. He stared at the thick forest in the back. He thought about Mitsuki. “I want to say goodbye to one more person.”

Tomura followed his gaze to the woods. He pursued his lips to the side but sighed in defeat.

“Okay,” Tomura agreed reluctantly. “One last look around but that’s it. Then we go home.”

Izuku and Tomura walked away from the car and towards the gravesite.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Through Golden Eyes

Himiko watched from inside of the car as Tomura and Izuku walked away. A bitter, putrid feeling tangled inside of her heart at the sight.

Izuku was let off easy—yet again. Izuku always managed to somehow be the one goddamn viper who didn't have to be perfect in order to survive. All because he got lucky and got Tomura as his Big.

Himiko gazed on with envy as Izuku and Tomura took a fucking sentimental stroll around the estate. She didn't need to hear to know it was probably because Izuku wanted 'one more look around' before departing. Always such a pathetic weakling. If this had been anyone else to run off with a goddamn outsider, they would have been gutted.

But because it was *Izuku*, he was saved.

Himiko glared at the estate, and wondered what life would have been like to experience that type of love. She had no doubt that whatever Izuku and that stranger Katsuki shared was potent and untouchable. But she couldn't help but feel deeply hurt as she thought about it.

Izuku and Katsuki cared for each other ever since they were kids.

It mirrored how she used to care for Sen in a similar way.

Sen was the boy from *her* childhood who was supposed to be her other half. Not in a romantic sense, but in a true, binding sibling love. Her Big Sister Kuin was always cold. She never felt like family, and the other vipers in their home were nothing but strangers to Himiko too.

Everyone's eyes would always pass her up unless she was displaying some sort of vicious act of bloodlust. All she wanted was to connect with someone, and she had. The very first true, human connection she ever felt was with Sen.

It happened on the day her Big Sister told her they were going to be killers at the tender age of five.

Her Big Sister Kuin made it no secret to her in the same way Jin made it no secret to Sen. Those two were never quite good at following the rules aboutt keeping the cohorts in the dark until they were ten. When both she and Sen grasped that they were being raised to kill, they knew they needed each other to survive the hell they were going to endure.

During those days in the basement, she would be beaten, starved, and locked in dark boxes. The only light she could cling to was the thought of Sen, her *true* brother, to help her through. And every day Sen waited for her. He would be standing there with everything she needed to help heal her wounds when no one else did. Like a real brother.

She thought they would grow up together and be two sibling souls who understood each other through everything. They were going to have each other's back and be safeguarded from the world by their fierceness.

But instead she was burdened to be alone for the rest of her life because Izuku stole her one life line.

And every day after, she was forced to watch as Izuku got let off easy.

When Himiko messed up, she was sent to the basement where their caretakers would torture her by breaking bones and pulling fingernails. But when Izuku messed up, Tomura took him up to their room and gave him a simple spanking with a belt. Then some nights, Tomura would even make Izuku his favorite ramen right after. It went on like this.

Himiko needed to be a perfect viper. Izuku got to be riddled with imperfection.

Himiko couldn't indulge in any fantasies. Izuku has a library of banned books.

Himiko couldn't feel love anymore. Izuku loved someone all his life.

The hypocrisy of higher standards she was held to wasn't fair—and because of that Himiko hated Izuku with every fiber of her being.

All she wanted was for Izuku to be dragged down to her level and feel what it was like to be truly alone in the world. He was always protected by that damn Tomura and now she learned he was always loved by this *Katsuki*. Izuku didn't know what it was like to be a real viper, and because of that she never would consider him family. Their suffering was not symmetrical.

She watched Tomura and Izuku disappear off to the back into the trees. The scornful look in her eyes amplified once they were out of sight.

She unlocked the car door.

She grabbed for her backpack and walked up to the door of the estate. The hate inside of her was boiling over, and there was no one else to blame except Izuku. Maybe if he never killed Sen then she would know compassion and reasoning like he did.

But he stole that away and now all she could feel was spite.

She picked the lock on the estate easily and slithered inside.

The quaintness of the home was nearly admirable. It was cozy enough for two and smelled like freshly baked pie. She curiously wandered into the bedroom to peer at Katsuki who was passed out on the bed. Dried tears were clinging to his cheeks as his body twitched in his unconscious state.

She scoffed at how pathetic he was too and was about to leave until something caught her eye. She walked up close to Katsuki and saw a letter neatly folded in his hands. She leaned in closely to see it was signed with 'To: Katsuki, From: Izuku' in shitty handwriting.

Himiko reached forward to pluck it from Katsuki's limp hands and opened it. A massive hill of papers greeted her and she leisurely skimmed the pages. As her eyes scanned through the paragraphs, she realized this was a detailed recounting of the death of Bakugou Mitsuki and an apology.

Every detail from that night was listed: How Izuku didn't see the folder and didn't know what Mitsuki looked like until he held up the sniper rifle. He even wrote that he tackled Himiko to stop her out of a strange instinct, which led to him running away for a short couple of hours.

Himiko was even surprised to learn through this letter how Tomura held a blade to Izuku's throat and *forced* him to pull the trigger. He had no clue what Mitsuki's name was at the time of the murder, or even when they spent time together. He said if he knew he would have confessed right away.

However, despite all this, Izuku reasonably stated he took full responsibility.

Himiko could tell Izuku gave this letter a lot of thought. It was almost admirable how well written it was. But she didn't bother to read more when it began to get too mushy for her liking.

When she stopped her skimming, she was surprised that even she found the letter to be touching despite her no longer having a heart to touch. Hell, Katsuki could potentially find the situation to be *understandable* if he read this. Then his stupid little heart would likely forgive Izuku if given appropriate time.

Himiko curled her lip in disgust at that thought.

She unzipped her backpack, tucked away Izuku's letter and pulled out the red folder for Bakugou Mitsuki that she had stolen from the records back home.

If what Tomura said was true, then Izuku's loose cannon of a boyfriend would come to kill him the second he opened this. Because without the explanation and just the plain, cold facts the situation looked terrible.

After all, misunderstandings were the number one relationship killer in romantic novels.

And even if Katsuki didn't succeed in killing Izuku, what better way to break Izuku's bleeding heart down into pieces? No hopeless romantic could emotionally recover from being nearly murdered by the person they loved the most in this world. It would be a taste of poetic tragedy and the cherry on top would be potentially blowing up whatever deal Tomura brokered with Chisaki.

Fuck them both.

She walked back into the kitchen and went straight for the sink. She wet her fingers slightly. Carefully, she flicked droplets across the folder to make it seem like Izuku was leaning over this sobbing his cry baby eyes out. It would be believable if his predictable ass tears were involved.

Her slender hand sat down the red folder on the kitchen table neatly.

“Rip his goddamn heart out, Katsuki,” Himiko whispered with scathing vengeance.

Chapter End Notes

buckles you in and pats your head

Thanks so much for reading!! Let me know your reactions below :)

Chapter 27: Senza

Chapter Summary

> Senza (Qualifier) - To be Without
>
> Izuku learns to learn what it is like to be without Katsuki.

Chapter Notes

> Hellooo!! Welcome back to this choochoo train of angst!
>
> First, thank you to the LOML Luna for betaing!! Secondly, I'm so excited to kick off this part of the fic :)) Small note, I know couple of people were asking about Katsuki's POV and his POV will come back eventually. The plot hinges on staying in Izuku's POV for a while longer, but there will be a flip to Katsuki and then it'll go to alternating POVs :) Thanks for your patience!
>
> I hope you all enjoy!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes



Chapter 27 — Senza

.

.

.

The rain storm picked up as soon as Tomura began driving away from the Bakugou estate.

Izuku sat quietly in the backseat while Himiko sat in the passenger side with Tomura next to her. The two of them chatted while Izuku watched as the sanctuary he'd grown used to faded into its surroundings.

His eyes never left the home as it grew smaller and smaller until it was no longer visible.

A sharp pain hit his chest the second he could no longer see it.

Izuku held back from crying as all the memories from the last four months danced in front of him, vivid as ever. He could hear Katsuki's voice and feel his callus touch. He could see his smile and smell the warmth of home cooked meals that they shared every day.

A new, unfamiliar emotion settled inside of him. It snuck into his body and wedged its way between his logic and his sanity. Izuku leaned his head against the window when suddenly it felt too heavy to keep upright.

His chest ached once more and suddenly Izuku knew what he was feeling.

He was experiencing his first heartbreak.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku stayed silent the whole ride back to Tokyo.

He didn't utter a single word, not even when prompted by either his brother or sister. He didn't speak not because he was pissed at them, but more so at himself. A list of regrets began to pile up. Should haves. Could haves. *Would* haves. He reviewed every painful flop he had done within the last month with agony.

Funny how now that he was separated from Katsuki, he felt like he knew how he should have handled everything. Hindsight truly was 20/20.

There was a piece of him that regretted not giving Katsuki the letter sooner. How could he have acted like everything was fine that last month? Izuku was utterly disgusted at himself for how well of an act he put up in Katsuki's face despite knowing what he did.

He really was a snake—wasn't he?

When they made it back into the city limits, Izuku felt nearly blinded by the neon lights. He squinted and lowered his head away from all the pulsing electronic screens.

"We're home," Himiko said a bit too cheerily. She turned in her seat to grin at Izuku with half mooned eyes. "Glad you got to enjoy a little vacation before getting right back to work."

Izuku lowered his head away from her. He leaned back on the leather seat to try to close his eyes. He heard his brother and sister murmuring in the front, probably about him.

When Izuku opened his eyes again, he caught Tomura looking at him through the rearview mirror.

“This is for the best, Izuku,” Tomura suddenly said. “Trust me. You’re going to forget all about this soon. We all make mistakes in life but we move on.”

“Well, Vipers don’t make mistakes,” Himiko added snidely. “But of course, Izuku does.”

Izuku had no energy to rebuttal.

By the time they reached the tall cluster of skyscrapers they called home, it was storming. The thick clouds trapped Tokyo in what felt like a dense snow globe of downpour and the sky was hardly visible. They circled around the back of their home and headed towards the garage area.

When they pulled into the driveway, Tomura clicked the button on his keys to open the black gates. They opened up slowly, perfectly welcoming them home with open arms.

Tomura pulled up straight to the back door, and both Izuku and Himiko made a move to get out once the car stopped.

“Izuku, you stay put,” Tomura commanded. “Himiko, you can go inside. Have a good rest of your night.”

Izuku frowned. He watched quietly as Himiko got out of the car like she knew what was about to happen. She held up her blood red umbrella, turned and said her goodbyes to them. She spared Izuku a single, knowing glance before walking away.

When Himiko was safely inside, Tomura began driving again—right out of the gates.

Izuku sat up all the way, confused. “Where are we going?”

“You are going to your new home,” Tomura replied. “You no longer live in the Viper Complex anymore.”

“*What*?” Izuku exclaimed. “What the hell do you mean—”

“Language,” Tomura harshly cut down. “Do not fix your mouth to use foul words towards me. Ever.”

Izuku bit his tongue. He had picked up cursing so flippantly from Katsuki. He lowered his head in respect and his heart rate increased.

“I’m sorry,” Izuku whispered. “I was surprised. Wh-What do you mean I don’t live in the complex anymore? What about Katsuma? How will I take care of him?”

“I moved both you and Katsuma to my oceanside property,” Tomura answered. “After I got the King Cobra title and salary, I started investing in real estate. I have a private house on the outskirts of Tokyo with enforced security. That’s where you will stay from now on.”

Izuku's mind began racing a mile per minute.

He was being isolated.

Never in history had a viper who was not a handler lived out of their complex. Hell, even Nine lived in the penthouse that they were staying in. Ms. Nagant and One were the only ones from their family who lived off the premises. But they were both still nearby.

This closeness was a key part of their family dynamic. It was to ensure that they were always together and had each other to train, talk, and rely on. It eliminated the need for social interaction outside of their own kind.

"May I ask why?" Izuku whispered. "This is…not protocol."

"Because of that dangerous blond," Tomura said curtly. "I told you I need you safe until Chisaki gives me power. So in the meantime, you will remain in a place that I know is well guarded. You will have no missions and you're not permitted to go outside. I'll have Jin and Ibara run errands for you until the day comes."

When they got back on the highway Izuku barely felt human. Instead, it was like he shape-shifted into some object being placed under lock and key.

Tomura glanced at him through the reflection and shook his head.

"Don't be so ungrateful, Izuku," Tomura lectured impatiently. "It's a whole house. You and Katsuma will practically have it to yourself. There's a pool, a room for each of you, and more. Besides, this way you'll get to spend unlimited time with Katsuma after neglecting him for so long to go act like a whore."

"Right," Izuku muttered. He forced himself to agree to avoid conflict. "Thank you for thinking of my safety."

"I always do."

After a few beats of silence, Izuku asked, "How long until the deal with Chisaki comes?"

"It's officially three weeks away."

Izuku probed his tongue on the inside of his cheek. He leaned back into the leather seat once more and resigned himself. He gazed back up at the sky through the window and caught the sight of several beads of rain that bled into each other.

Three weeks of isolation.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When they arrived near Tomura's private property, it was as remote as he promised.

They drove to a wooded area where the road turned nearly dirt like until they arrived at spiked, silver gates. They were lined with intricate details of horned vipers, mimicking the

endless viper tattoos that were inked on Tomura's skin.

Tomura pulled up to the keypad and punched in a code. Slowly, the new gates opened for them to reveal a well-kept driveway. They drove up the pavement until the sight of a luxurious home came into view.

It was embedded into the side of the cliff and appeared posher than the homes in the magazines Izuku would sometimes flip through. The sleek all black color had silver accents and large dark colored curtains blocked off the glass windows that were stand-in walls.

As they drew closer, Izuku could see several familiar faces.

All of the guards were lower ranked Vipers. They stood around the entire perimeter with long rifles, hand guns, and even katanas secured to their backs. They were dressed in all white and their sharp eyes were homed in on the car as they approached.

Tomura parked his vehicle in the front and the gates behind him closed.

Izuku slowly got out of the car with his umbrella opened. Tomura popped the trunk and they both grabbed for his bags. As they walked up the luxe stairs to his new home, Izuku felt all the eyes of the lower ranked Vipers on him.

Some of them whispered to themselves and others gave him a cold stare.

Tomura unlocked the doors and upon entry Izuku looked around. Everything was decorated exactly to Tomura's well refined tastes. All black, leather and minimal decor. It was sterile just like their primary home and Izuku immediately missed the coziness of the Bakugou estate.

"C'mon, let me show you where everything is," Tomura said.

They both took their shoes off, put down their umbrellas, and began to walk around.

Izuku stayed quiet as Tomura showed him all the different rooms. Four bathrooms. Five bedrooms. Katsuma's bedroom was right next to Izuku's and there was a home movie theater. At the very top of the house was a sunroom filled with plants, and the kitchen was a rustic modern decor with four stoves.

It was perfect, really. Packed to the brim with everything someone could want.

There was so much space here that if this was a mere six months ago, Izuku would have been thrilled.

He finally got his own home separate from Tomura—but now all he could feel was loneliness. Even with all this extravagance, nothing would feel like home ever again now that he knew what it was like to be with Katsuki. And now he knew, all this glitter they were bathed in was nothing more than shackles made of silver and gold.

"And lastly, this is your new library," Tomura announced when they approached the last room.

Izuku snapped out of his mindless daze when the door pushed open.

Endless rows and rows of books towered over them. The shelves reached up to the high ceiling, covering the entirety of three out of four walls. On the fourth wall was a large window shielded by black curtains and there was a sleek reading chair tucked in the corner.

Izuku walked into the center of the room, slowly. He looked up at the endless books.

“I figured this would be something you would like,” Tomura said. “All romance novels. Now you can indulge in your defective fantasies whenever you please without the need to go out searching for it.”

Izuku turned to Tomura. His brother was gazing at him waiting for his response.

Izuku quickly faked happiness the best he could and bowed respectfully.

“Thank you for always thinking of me,” Izuku whispered.

“Of course,” Tomura said. “Now, I have to get back to the penthouse, but in the meantime I have asked Jin and Ibara to come by in the morning and drop off groceries for you and Katsuma. They’ll come by once a week to give you two fresh foods and if there’s anything you need, contact Ibara directly. Okay?”

“Okay,” Izuku said in a small voice.

“I have to get back to Tokyo now. Get a goodnight’s rest, Izuku.”

“You too.”

Tomura spared one more pity filled glance and walked away. The door to the library closed, leaving Izuku there by himself in the middle of the room.

Izuku stayed still, waiting until he heard the front door open and shut. When he was officially alone in this large house, the numbness finally settled back in. The heartbreak that had found itself a home in his chest was back again, and this time it ached to be tended to.

Izuku turned to the books behind him to give his hurting soul what it wanted.

He walked forward and grabbed the first book at eye level. He opened it, read the first few lines and then placed it on the ground. He did this again and again until there was a pile next to his feet. He tried to gather all the books he might begin with, hoping to shove something inside of him to satisfy this void in his chest like he always used to.

With a light wobble, Izuku sat down on the expensive carpet.

He began to read the first book he picked out. He viewed the words through his bleary vision, hoping this would be the fix to drown out all the memories that were tormenting him. He read the first line, but immediately compared it to a memory he shared with Katsuki.

He kept on reading, but soon found himself unwillingly comparing every scene to real life.

Izuku figured it was this one book that didn't quite meet his needs so he put it down. He grabbed for the next one but the same thing happened. More memories overshadowed the scenes and made it impossible for him to get swept away in the fantasy world.

Izuku then grabbed for the next book and then the next and once again the next.

Izuku read passage after passage and discarded every book the moment it failed to catch his interest. Every sentence fell flat and no scene spoke to his heart the way it used to. What used to inspire hope now only added to the growing void deep inside of him. The ache in his chest was hungry and it was demanding to be fed—but no book could satisfy him.

Izuku stopped his motions.

He placed down the book in his hands in his lap and gazed up at the endless wall of novels.

It was then Izuku understood why this wasn't working.

None of these stories would ever really compare to his and Katsuki's.

Izuku now accepted that his romance books and movies were all coping mechanisms. Every beautiful metaphor and simile he read was a lazy patch job for the hole inside of him. He thought if he piled enough whimsical stories on top of the void in his heart, he could ignore the emptiness inside of him for the rest of his miserable life.

But he made one miscalculation. He never expected to know what it really felt like to be loved. To be held. To be wanted so deeply that he felt it through all his past lives. He could never go back to simply daydreaming about romance as a concept now that he knew the concrete thing.

No story he would ever indulge in again could hold a candle to the love Katsuki had shown him.

And now, nothing could ease the ache in his chest except one, singular person.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku walked up to Katsuma's room with his bags.

He only meant to peek in, but was surprised to see Katsuma's big brown eyes peeking at him from under the covers.

Izuku's heart lit up and his eyes brightened immediately. He playfully cocked his head at his little brother and immediately Katsuma giggled and waved.

"Hi 'Zuku!" Katsuma whispered and kicked his feet a little under the covers. "I-I missed you so much!"

Izuku grinned ear to ear. He placed down his bags and walked over to Katsuma. Immediately, the ache in his heart quelled a little.

“I missed you too, buddy,” Izuku said. He sat down beside the tiny bed and stroked Katsuma’s hair. His little brother glanced towards the door. Izuku turned to look over his shoulder too, and understood who Katsuma was checking for. Izuku turned back to Katsuma and gave a sad, reassured smile. “He’s gone. It’s going to be only us from now on.”

At this, Katsuma seemed nervous but happy. “Only us?”

Izuku hummed and nodded. “Yup. Sometimes Jin and Ibara will come by but it’ll be just me and you, buddy. Now, what are you doing awake? It’s so late.”

“I heard the door open and then I heard your voice,” Katsuma replied shyly. “I…I wanted to see you. It’s been a long time.”

“I’m sorry for going away,” Izuku said. He painfully smiled as the ache in his heart for Katsuki tripled. But he shoved it down as he looked at the small child in front of him. “I…I got distracted.”

“It’s okay, you’re back now,” Katsuma replied happily. “Did you have fun while you were away?”

“I did. I had the most fun I ever had in my life,” Izuku said with a woeful undertone. He laughed lightly and blinked back the sting of tears. “I’m really happy I got to go away for a while.”

“Can you tell me about it?”

“How about I tell you in the morning? You need your sleep.”

Katsuma bit his lip. He looked down at his small fingers and fiddled with them nervously. “Can…Can you sleep in here with me? This house makes me scared.”

“Of course I can,” Izuku agreed without a second thought. “Let me go get my blankets and we can have a sleepover.”

Katsuma grinned wide and happily clapped his hands together. Izuku laughed and leaned in to hug him, but right as he did, Katsuma lifted his arms from under the covers. Izuku’s eyes stretched wide in horror and his heart dropped to his lowest parts.

There was a yellowish purple bruise wrapped around Katsuma’s arm.

“Katsuma, h-how’d you get that mark?” Izuku immediately exclaimed.

Quickly, the excitement drained from his little brother’s face. Katsuma sunk further into the blankets and quickly hid his arms as if he was ashamed. Izuku stared in horror as what felt like a mirror of his younger self did *exactly* what he used to.

Suddenly, the ache in Izuku’s chest twisted into anger. Rage, even. His nostrils flared at the thought of someone hurting Katsuma while he was away.

“Katsuma. Tell me now,” Izuku said sternly.

“I…” Katsuma started and stumbled over his words. “Me and Kota were playing and I fell when he pushed me. I hurt my knee and I started cr-crying. Then brother Jin punished me for crying. He said it was bad and that I should have pushed Kota back. He said if I cried again he would punish me more.”

Izuku’s anger flared so intensely it almost startled him.

Never before had such pure disdain swallowed him so quickly. It overpowered all the sadness that was in his body and hollowed out his empathy. It seared at all his broken insides and his eyes homed in on the bruise.

His miserable childhood flashed before him. He could vividly remember every slap, punch, and scratch Tomura inflicted on him. The mere thought of Jin daring to put his hands on Katsuma without his permission made Izuku furious.

Without effort, Izuku imagined breaking Jin’s hands. He could feel the ghost crunch of each bone under his fists and a part of him yearned for it.

“Next time one of them touches Katsuma you should kill them,” The voice of Hiryu said in the back of his mind.

At that taboo thought, Izuku quickly shook his head and snapped himself out of it.

In order to calm himself back down, Izuku tended to Katsuma’s wound. There wasn’t much he could do since it was already so old which made him upset with himself.

He should have been here to prevent it.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Later that night, Izuku laid on the floor beside Katsuma’s bed in a heap of blankets.

Katsuma was fast asleep but Izuku was wide awake looking up at the blank ceiling. Izuku realized now that he needed to get Katsuma and all the other kids out *immediately*. They were coming of age and Izuku would never forgive himself if Katsuma began to carry the same traumas as him.

He considered the order of things.

As much as he wanted to get Katsuma out now, he understood he couldn’t. Tomura had guards waiting at all exits of this lavish prison. He needed an opening where he could get all the kids in one go, and potentially disappear for at least a week.

With his tracker now separate from him, Izuku knew this would be easier. But he wouldn’t resume assignments until after the consummation with Chisaki.

Which meant in order for Katsuma’s future to be secured, he needed to let Chisaki have his way with him.

Izuku's stomach turned sick at the thought. But as he looked over at the sleeping child next to him, he knew he would have to entertain Chisaki the best he could if he wanted to get out of this house. Then immediately after, he needed to get Katsuma out before the power exchange could be complete.

Izuku was still unsure what kind of chaos would rain down once Tomura got that seat at the Underground Council. From what he remembered, Chisaki wasn't signing any of the papers until after he got what he wanted.

But then there was the matter of *killing* Chisaki.

Chisaki was at the top of his death list and it was a priority to strip his life away from him. However, when he killed Chisaki he would likely be hunted down and eventually found out. Izuku sucked at his teeth as he went over every scenario he could in his head.

There was only one real option: he would have to flee.

No matter what, in the end, the only answer was Izuku disappearing after both things were finished if he wanted to keep his life.

If this had been before Katsuki, Izuku likely would have simply accepted death. But now that he knew what it was like to truly live and not simply survive—Izuku was unsure if he wanted to die. He wanted to experience a beautiful life more and if that meant blowing up everything before going, he would light up everything with glee.

Izuku concluded that the kids came first, however.

He would get the kids out and directly after doing that, he would go and kill Chisaki. Then he would disappear.

After all that was said and done, Izuku would accept whatever fate waited for him.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When morning came, Izuku admittedly was checking his phone.

He refreshed his empty call log over and over, slightly disappointed but not surprised. The poison he gave Katsuki should have worn off by now, and likely he would have read the letter. Part of Izuku was hoping Katsuki would call and cuss him out immediately, but nothing came.

Shortly after Izuku got Katsuma ready for the day, Ibara and Jin came with bags of groceries just like Tomura said.

Upon entry, they greeted each other. Ibara hugged him warmly and Jin ruffled his hair. Izuku tried his best to hide his disdain for Jin and kept a forced smile pinned to his face. When Jin's back was turned however, Izuku glared daggers into the back of his skull.

Right before they were about to leave, Izuku politely asked his siblings if they wanted to stay for breakfast. He insisted since they had traveled all this way. He wanted the company a bit, but also he wanted to hear about what was happening at home.

Ibara and Jin both happily agreed and sat down at the steel table with Katsuma.

As Izuku chopped vegetables, Jin and Ibara chatted behind him about casual matters.

“So, Izuku. How was Bangkok?” Jin asked with a grin.

Izuku paused his chopping and turned around. Part of him was surprised Himiko hadn’t told Jin the truth, but Izuku realized Tomura likely threatened her to stay quiet.

Izuku gave a meek nod and said, “It was good. I ate a lot of tasty street food and had some fun in Phuket.”

“Ugh, I’m so freakin’ jealous.” Jin exasperated. He threw his head back and dramatically slouched in the chair. “You have the Thailand glow, I can practically *smell* the happiness radiating off of you. Next time bring me with you!”

Izuku laughed and nodded. “I will.”

“So. Are you excited about getting with Chisaki soon?” Ibara then interjected.

At that, Izuku froze.

His eyes widened and he glanced between them as he said, “You two know about that?”

“Well duh,” Jin said with a shrug. “Most people in the underground know about it by now. After you were gone to Bangkok for so long, a lot of your regular admirers were wondering where you were. They started talking about how they missed ogling your big pretty green eyes and taking bets on who would pop your cherry first. And I guess that made Chisaki possessive.”

“Yeah,” Ibara agreed. She smiled gently and tilted her head at Izuku. “Chisaki started saying how you were off limits to everyone but *him* to all his Yakuza men. And you know how the grapevine works. One person tells another and another and another. Next thing you know, the rumored affair of the beautiful Viridian Viper and the most powerful Yakuza heir in history is running around like wildfire.”

“Might as well be the closest thing to a royal wedding Hadeus will ever see,” Jin said with a slight snark. “A lot of people are invested in how it’ll go between you two.”

“He’s hosting a big event, y’know,” Ibara said and Izuku’s eyebrows flew up on his face. “A masquerade ball with an orchestra and everything. He said he wanted to make your first night together an event no one would ever forget.”

Izuku swallowed. He shifted uncomfortably on his feet a bit.

This was quite a big show for his ‘deflowering’. It nearly felt like a coming out party for him and Chisaki dating rather than a perverse business arrangement.

“That’s very kind of him,” Izuku said quietly.

“Very,” Ibara agreed. She grinned. “You’re very lucky to have caught his eye! Ah, my little brother has the Yakuza Heir fawning over him. How exciting.”

“All of this is a bit flashy if you ask me,” Jin muttered. “But, you boost his social currency in a way. And vice versa. Way to aim high, Izuku. I’m impressed.”

“You even found someone Tomura approved of,” Ibara added sweetly. “That’s what’s most important.”

Izuku forced a shy smile and went back to chopping.

As he sliced each carrot on the cutting board into tiny pieces, he imagined them to be Chisaki’s greedy fingers.

ᔓᔓᔓ

The first week alone in the house was quiet and quaint.

Neither he or Katsuma were particularly fond of the cold mansion, but they enjoyed the solitude away from their ruthless family.

It was here that Izuku got to see Katsuma’s shy personality slip away a bit. He was more openly himself without the other vipers looming over him. They happily played pretend, dressed up, and ran around the large home as if they were on a safari.

As they did this, Izuku still periodically checked his phone.

In hindsight, he wished he had asked Katsuki for his number. But he knew it was for the best like amputating a dead limb that would only drag him down in the end.

When a full week passed and he still hadn’t heard from Katsuki, Izuku presumed Katsuki read his letter and decided he wanted nothing to do with him. It made sense. Admittedly, Izuku thought Katsuki’s temper would make him call.

An inkling of him was looking forward to hearing Katsuki’s voice, even if it was yelling at him. Part of him even hoped Katsuki would stay true to his promise to always be chasing behind him.

But this was somehow worse.

At the end of the week, Izuku kept his promise that he put in the letter and drew up the divorce papers.

He had the documents specially ordered and mailed to the mansion. He signed them with a numbness and quietly put them in an envelope. As he wrote a fake return address and the

Bakugou estate's address on the front of the envelope, he felt a piece of his soul be mangled.

It felt like an important part of him was losing circulation, strangled by his guilt.

A single tear escaped and landed on the paper and he quickly wiped it away.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When Jin and Ibara came to the mansion again to deliver food, Izuku privately asked Ibara to put the envelope in the mail.

She nodded, not questioning anything and put the document in her purse. As if she could sense something was wrong, she quietly rubbed his shoulders that morning and offered to cook breakfast for them instead of Izuku.

Izuku appreciated this in silence as he took a seat at the steel kitchen table. The cold surface pressed against his skin exactly matched the numbness in his core. He sat next to Katsuma who was toying with his iPad playing a colorful game for kids.

Izuku then decided to redirect all his energy to Katsuma. He needed to keep focused on the most important things for now.

"How is everything back at home?" Izuku asked quietly.

"It's hectic," Jin answered seriously. His usual goofy demeanor was gone as he strummed his fingers on the table. "Someone nearly breached our security systems recently."

"What? How is that possible?" Izuku asked, entirely surprised.

"We don't know," Jin said quietly. A crease in his brow formed as he stared at the steam coming from his tea cup. "Clearly, it's not the first attempt to hack into our network, but it was a rather advanced one according to Aoyama. The system glitched for exactly two seconds and someone nearly got in through the garage gate without triggering the alarms."

"We got security footage of someone in all black circling around the building," Ibara added. She walked over to the table with a plate of food for Katsuma and Izuku. "It was a man. A bit tall and built but he covered his face, hair, and all his skin with jet black clothing. He even wore visors to cover his eyes."

"Is there any clue who it was?" Izuku questioned.

"The list of suspects is too fucking long," Jin groaned. "Between all the people the Yakuza, the Governor and The Academy have pissed off, it could honestly be anyone. But it has to be someone fucking stupid to have the gall to test the Vipers."

"The important thing is whoever it was didn't make it through," Ibara said. "They must know about our inner workings, so it must be someone who had some sort of business with us. Tomura is interrogating people now."

She sat down with her and Jin's food and sighed.

"Yeah," Jin muttered. "We tried to catch the guy, but the fucker sped off on an unmarked motorcycle and his maneuvering was a bit too expert to keep up on foot. By the time we mobilized in vehicles, he was gone in the rush hour traffic. And you know how dense Tokyo can get."

"That's…" Izuku paused at an unsure thought. "Strange."

"It is," Jin said. "Count yourself lucky Tomura moved you out. You can relax here on the oceanside in peace while everyone at home is running around trying to find the guy. But it's not a big issue. No one can take us on. The fucker must have a death wish to go poking at the nest."

Izuku began to quietly eat.

The topic shifted to something else naturally. Overall, Ibara and Jin didn't seem too phased by the attempted break in. But Izuku couldn't help but wonder. He thought back to Okinawa and remembered how easily Katsuki hacked into Moore's systems to get blueprints of Ie Island.

ᔓᔓᔓ

The second week alone in the mansion, Izuku finally began to get used to the quiet.

Him and Katsuma went swimming in the indoor pool and found an enjoyable routine. Izuku's heart filled with light every time he saw Katsuma smile and was overjoyed to be giving Katsuma happy memories instead of painful ones.

Half way through the week, Izuku's phone buzzed in his pocket for the first time while he was getting snacks from the kitchen. He pulled out the device quickly. His heart began hammering like a drum as he thought it might be Katsuki.

But it wasn't. He clicked open the text app to see Ibara's contact instead.

[199]: I put that envelope in the mail for you. If you need anything else, let me know.

Izuku deflated. His eyes dulled as he typed his response.

[You]: Thank you so much, I owe you one

[199]: It's no problem :) Tell Katsuma hello for me.

Izuku put his phone away.

He wandered into the living room with a bowl of popcorn like a lost soul. He wordlessly sat down on the cold leather couch next to Katsuma who was watching some sort of cartoon. He sunk into his thoughts as he stared at the figures on the screen.

Why was he so sad that Katsuki hadn't reached out? He knew he didn't deserve to be.

By the end of the second week, Izuku accepted the fact Katsuki likely hated him. He knew the divorce papers should have made it to Biei by now. It was likely that Katsuki signed them and submitted them to the local ward office.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When Jin and Ibara came by for the third, and final time, Izuku could feel something was different. The air was chillier and felt thinner. He couldn't quite place it, but something shifted in the atmosphere.

This time, Jin cooked breakfast for them while Izuku and Ibara relaxed at the table. His two siblings were casually chatting and laughing about missions they had recently gone on. They also kept Izuku in the loop with everything happening back home.

"They never found the guy by the way," Jin said as he placed all the savory food on the table.

"Really?" Izuku questioned.

"Yup," Jin said with a pop of his lips. "Dude vanished with the wind. Not a trace left behind."

"I'm sure it's nothing," Ibara interjected. She waved her hand and began eating. "The poor soul probably realized what he was doing and crawled back to whatever hole he came from. He must be smart to value his life and leave us alone."

Izuku hummed in agreement but truthfully he was slightly astonished.

No one had really gotten away that easily after poking at Vipers. It took a lot of effort and skill to do something like that without leaving behind any evidence. Especially after making a hasty getaway.

Without much effort, Izuku's mind wandered to how Katsuki perfectly killed Imasuji Goto without a trace.

ᔓᔓᔓ

As the third and final week came to a countdown, Izuku found himself revisiting all his lovely memories with Katsuki.

Before he left Biei, Izuku had taken the DVD of their vows and all the pictures Katsuki had hung up around the estate. Originally, he had taken these items with the intention of destroying them. He wanted to make sure there was no proof of their forbidden union, just in case it somehow circulated back to Chisaki.

This was done out of love, because he didn't want Katsuki to be put in harm's way.

But Izuku couldn't bring himself to go through with killing all the evidence.

Instead, he found himself fondly looking at everything. He watched the DVD over and over again because now it was the only romantic movie he cared to see.

Izuku sat on the couch with the box of pictures while in the background the video of him and Katsuki's vows ran.

Beside him Katsuma played with his toys on the floor by the large window that served as a wall. In the background the thick cluster of trees blended in with the night. Katsuma mumbled to himself and giggled as he made silly sounds with his toy cars.

Izuku half paid attention to Katsuma as he gazed at the photograph in his hand. It was of him and Katsuki wearing flower crowns, laying on the grass. They had cheesy grins on their face and the look in both of their eyes seemed so hopeful. Izuku lightly traced Katsuki's smile with his fingers while listening to Katsuki's voice in the background.

"I promise to always come back to you, darling," the Katsuki on the screen said sweetly.

Izuku looked up from the picture and studied the way Katsuki's beautiful eyes gazed at him at that moment. Izuku wished he could be transported inside of the TV as the Katsuki from the past gripped his hands tightly.

Izuku smiled sadly as they both slightly wobbled with matching plastered grins.

"I'll find my way back to you, again and again and again," TV Katsuki announced. "I promise to always be by your side and I'll kill—"

Suddenly, Katsuma screamed out.

Izuku was startled so hard he dropped the photograph. He whirled his head to Katsuma who was backing away from the window. Katsuma's eyes were wide with fear as he scrambled up to his feet. He rushed towards Izuku and hugged his legs.

"Wh-What's wrong?!" Izuku asked hastily.

He stood up quickly and hoisted Katsuma up in his arms. His little brother buried his face into his neck and clung tightly to him.

"Th-There's a monster outside," Katsuma exclaimed with a terrified voice. "With sc-scary eyes!"

A cold chill slipped down Izuku's spine.

Izuku cautiously glanced at the window. He slowly got his handgun from under the couch cushion. He held Katsuma up with one arm as he expertly cocked his gun with one hand.

He approached the window with caution and squinted.

Truthfully, he could barely see anything past the glare from the lights inside the house. It was too dark outside to see anything past the blackness that was shrouding the trees. He tried to

listen for something but it was impossible. The wind outside was howling like an animal in its own right.

Izuku came face to face with the thin glass and tried his best to see outside but found nothing but his own reflection.

However, a feeling he couldn't shake stuck to him.

"…What color eyes?" Izuku asked carefully.

"Red," Katsuma meekly answered.

A prickle jabbed at Izuku's neck.

He quickly glanced over to the TV that had Katsuki's smiling face on it.

He returned his eyes outside the window. His heart skipped a beat as he felt like his vision began to play tricks on him with the distorted blurry shapes he was seeing. Izuku stayed rooted in the same spot until nothing arrived. Izuku then gripped the gun in his hand and furrowed his brow.

Izuku backed away from the window, holding Katsuma closer. He quickly went to the front and back doors to see if the guards were still outside. He peaked out the windows and saw the guards were all there, making their rounds.

They were poised like nothing happened. All of them had their guns loaded, lazily talking between each other as they walked around the perimeter.

"Was it one of these guys?" Izuku whispered to Katsuma.

"No," Katsuma said confidently. "It was a monster with red eyes."

Izuku frowned.

Part of him knew he should do the adult thing and tell his little brother there was no such thing as monsters. But this type of outburst wasn't like Katsuma. And Izuku knew all monsters were based on real things. While it may not have been a supernatural creature, it very much could have been a person.

And frankly, that was far scarier.

ɯɯɯ

Later that night, Izuku slept in the room with Katsuma with the lights on. When his little brother was fast asleep, Izuku went back with his gun to the living room window and looked out of it. He waited and waited, trying to assess what exactly spooked Katsuma that badly.

But he saw nothing yet again.

However, deep into the darkness, Izuku was unsure if it was a shadow or a figure he saw shift in the distance.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When the day of the consummation finally came, Izuku tried his best not to be nervous. He was picking at his hands and jittering his legs all morning.

The moment Tomura finally arrived at the door, a gust of cold wind blew in with him. Behind him was Aoyama with a tiny, small smile.

Izuku shivered slightly as he greeted his brothers at the door.

They both greeted him back, and Izuku took a moment to take in both of their appearances.

Aoyama was dressed in casual blue sweats. His hair was messy and in his hands was a bunch of the usual gear he carried around for babysitting. Tomura on the other hand was dressed as if he was going to the most important event of his life.

Tomura was wearing an expensive black and silver suit. His tie was of silver snakes and his earrings were black studs. Hanging on his shoulders loosely was a jet black winter coat that had mink fur around the collar. His hair was neatly combed back into his signature half up half down style with a red hair tie.

However, what was in his gloved hands is what caught Izuku's eye the most.

"What is that?" Izuku questioned.

He pointed at the giant black box that was donned with a dark green ribbon.

"A gift from me," Tomura replied. He jutted his chin to the stairs as he took off his shoes. "Let's go up to your room."

Aoyama smiled at him as Katsuma ran up and greeted them all. The excited child waved at Aoyama and wearily glanced at Tomura. Tomura didn't seem to care, or mind. In fact, he seemed happy that Katsuma feared him. Aoyama playfully smiled at Katsuma and took his tiny hand in his. They both waved goodbye to Izuku and walked towards the living room where all the toys were.

With a heavy heart, Izuku then turned around and began walking upstairs with Tomura behind him. When Tomura shut the door Izuku felt the timer begin to count down on his life changing.

Tomura laid out the large black box on the bed and undid the ribbon. He lifted the lid up and pulled out one of the most gorgeous pieces of clothing Izuku had ever seen.

A black high collar lace shirt unfurled from his hands. It held an intricate pattern of vipers woven in and out of the design. At the collar was a dark green necktie that was a shade of viridian so deep it nearly blended in with the black color of the lace. To match it, in the box

laid a pair of sleek black slacks, a formal black blazer, and a viridian pocket square that matched the neck tie.

“I got this custom made for you a while ago,” Tomura said as he handed Izuku the shirt. “It’s tailor made to help emphasize all your best qualities.”

Izuku noted there were no buttons on the front of the blouse. Confused, he curiously turned it over. A long string of velvet green buttons ran down the back.

“This is…intimate,” Izuku muttered.

“I figured a garment that you would need assistance getting out of would be something Chisaki would enjoy,” Tomura said. “It’ll help him feel like the dominant man he pretends to be.”

Izuku didn’t say anything to that.

He glanced down in the box and saw his masquerade mask. He placed down the shirt in exchange for the mask and glanced it over.

It had the same intricate design as the shirt but with one slightly different touch: emeralds.

Gorgeous emeralds shone under the light. They were embedded into the sides of the mask, lining the cut out for his eyes. Surely this was to draw attention to one of his better physical features. Falling from the bottom of the mask were long strings of emeralds beaded together into tassels. They would act like a thin veil over the lower half of his face.

Izuku had to admit it was beautiful. But it was beautiful in the worst way.

“Let’s get you ready,” Tomura said when he saw Izuku come to a complete stand still. “Chisaki will be here to pick us up in two hours.”

Izuku gripped the mask tightly as Tomura placed his hands on his shoulders.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When Tomura fastened the last button on his shirt, Izuku felt like he was wrapped entirely in new skin. The clothes were soft against his flesh and it hugged every bit of him perfectly.

They stood together in silence in front of the full length mirror. Izuku barely recognized himself with the way Tomura dolled him up. He used cherry colored lip plumper and added concealer to smooth out his face. Izuku was surprised his brother knew his way around blush and eyeshadow when he expertly added a bit of rosiness to Izuku’s cheeks.

“How do I look?” Izuku whispered.

Tomura pushed a curl behind Izuku’s ear. “Expensive.”

Tomura picked up the mask and tied it to Izuku’s face, adding the final finishing touch.

Izuku's eyes glanced away from his reflection and Tomura placed his hands on his arms. He rubbed them lightly, trying to soothe some of the tension out of him.

"Thank you for doing this," Tomura said sincerely. "After this is over, we'll have more power than you can imagine and things like this will be a thing of the past. The second I get a seat at that table, I'll begin to run the underground in a way that I think is proper. And us Vipers will be at the top of the food chain soon."

Izuku nodded, and the light jingle of his mask bounced with him. "I understand."

Tomura then got a call. The quickness in which Tomura answered the phone told Izuku it was only one person. His suspicions were confirmed when he recognized the muffled voice on the other end as Chisaki. He heard him say that they were on their way and would be at the mansion within thirty minutes.

Tomura agreed and then asked to discuss some sort of last minute condition.

Before Izuku could hear what it was, Tomura excused himself. He walked out of Izuku's room to talk privately on the phone and shut the door.

As Tomura soon was out of sight, Izuku went over to his nightstand.

From his drawer, he pulled out the tiny silver bracelet with the locket that held his tracker.

He quickly glanced at the door and secured the bracelet around his ankle and tucked it into his sock. He pulled down his pant leg over the chunk and took a deep breath in. He rushed over to his suitcase and quickly shoved his notebook, laptop and the black folder with Nana's information inside. He zipped up his suitcase tightly with trembling hands.

Izuku looked at himself in the mirror one last time and let out a shaky exhale.

"Let's get started," Izuku whispered to himself.

ᔓᔓᔓ

They walked out of the mansion into the cold night and Izuku shivered immediately. The wind cut straight through him and left a frigid touch behind.

"Looks like winter arrived early this year," Tomura muttered as he shifted on his feet. "Usually that's an omen for bad luck. Be mindful not to jinx anything tonight."

Right as Izuku was about to respond, he suddenly heard a rustle in the distance.

He turned his head at the motion. An ominous feeling of intense eyes watching them sink into him like a knife. He blinked rapidly when the feeling was strangely familiar and whirled around to the density of barren trees in the back.

"Did you hear that?" Izuku asked quietly.

“I did,” Tomura said, but he didn’t seem phased. “There’s a lot of wildlife out here. The early winter winds are probably making them move around for hibernation.”

Izuku’s lips pulled into a tight frown. He waited for the rustle to happen again—but it didn’t.

“An animal that only moves once?” Izuku questioned, unsure.

“It’s probably just spooked, Izuku,” Tomura grumbled with short patience. He then lifted up his own small, black mask that was composed of silver etchings and tied it around his face. “Now, look forward. They’re here.”

Izuku turned his head to see the expensive gates of the mansion open wide.

Pouring in came a long line of unmarked black cars.

At least ten vehicles drove up in front of the mansion in perfect unification. Each was freshly washed with perfectly shined golden rims. Izuku didn’t see too many vehicles that rivaled Jin’s sports car collection, but these definitely did. He supposed if there was anyone who had wealth to envy, it would be Chisaki.

In the middle of the cluster of cars was a long, expensive limo. The side was embellished with a golden sigil of the Shie Hassaikai.

The limo pulled up directly in front of Tomura and Izuku. When the window rolled down, awaiting him with a perfectly sharp smile was Chisaki. He was wearing a simple black and gold masquerade mask.

Izuku and Tomura both bowed in sync and said respectful greetings.

The driver of the limo got out of the car and hurried around to take Izuku’s bag. He carried it off to the trunk and tightly shut the lid. He came back around and politely smiled as he opened the door for them.

The interior of the limo was lined with regal leather seats. Chisaki sat inside patiently along with two bodyguards, and the white haired man Izuku recognized as Chisaki’s assistant.

All of Izuku’s anxieties manifested in that single moment and became glue at the bottom of his feet. He was stuck, frozen in place.

This was really it.

Tomura gave the small of his back a light push, making him step forward to get in the limo. As Izuku climbed in, he couldn’t shake the feeling of being watched.

He glanced at the dark gathering of trees one more time. Then he slid into the limousine all the way to the window.

Tomura climbed in after him, sliding in to sit next to Izuku. Across from them, the Yakuza members sat silently. Izuku sniffed lightly when he got a whiff of the faint smell of cigars

lingering in the space. The driver shut the door, locking them in and soon the entourage of expensive cars began to drive.

Izuku watched out the window of the limo as the mansion began to grow smaller and smaller in the background.

He saw the tiny silhouette of Katsuma in the front window right before the gates shut tight. As they drove deeper into the night to the city, Izuku turned to look at Chisaki. His future bed mate's eyes were glued to him like he was a prize dangling on a string.

"You look ravishing, Izuku," Chisaki complimented with his voice as smooth as velvet. "A mask made of emeralds does your beauty justice."

"Thank you, Mr. Chisaki," Izuku said quietly. "My brother picked it out."

"Well. Your brother has good taste," Chisaki agreed with a light chuckle. "Also, please. Call me Kai. I told you that last time we spoke."

Izuku began to respond but was cut off by Tomura.

"He'll start to call you Kai after the papers are signed," Tomura said curtly. He folded his hands neatly over his crossed legs and cocked his head. "Did you bring the documents?"

"I did," Chisaki replied tightly.

He looked at Tomura with a level of annoyance. But the second he glanced at Izuku it melted away. He snapped his fingers and in a dash of lightning, his assistant pulled out a leather briefcase.

The assistant revealed a thick stack of neatly organized papers. He began to slowly hand them to Tomura one by one with a clipboard. With every stack of papers he gave, they discussed business conditions for being a Pillar on the Council.

It slowly dawned on Izuku what was happening: Tomura had somehow negotiated getting everything signed before the consummation.

Which meant that he went into power effectively-immediately.

White noise sliced through Izuku's head as he watched his brother sign dotted lines.

Everyone's voices muffled as Izuku stared in horror at every signature Tomura gave. He wearily glanced between Tomura and Chisaki as his thoughts began racing. He wrung his hands tightly in his lap. The ticking time bomb to get the kids out began *now*.

Izuku quickly turned his head to the window to hide his distress.

As they began to approach Tokyo, the density in traffic picked up. The Yakuza cars perfectly surrounded the limo in the front, the back, and on the sides.

Izuku stared out the window watching the busy people and buildings go by as quickly as his thoughts.

“Papers are all officially signed,” Chisaki’s assistant said after several long minutes. He smiled stiffly and bowed his head. “Welcome to The Underground Council, Mr. Mamushi.”

Chisaki smirked as he shook hands with Tomura. He chuckled and said, “You’ll need an official code name now for joining the Council. Have you decided on what that will be?”

Izuku cut his eye to his brother.

The void inside of Tomura’s eyes grew hungrier. He tilted his chin down and smirked with dark pleasure.

“I choose the name of Shigaraki,” Tomura said confidently.

A new type of cold washed over Izuku.

Izuku saw the greed in his brother’s eyes grow exponentially as he looked at Chisaki. No longer was Tomura seeing Chisaki as a person. Instead, he was viewing Chisaki as the first step in his total control of Tokyo.

Izuku felt woozy as he shifted in his seat. He gripped his dress pants and turned his head away again once they hit a red light.

But this time when he looked out the window, awaiting him was a biker dressed in scarlet right beside his window in the car.

Izuku was taken back by the closeness.

Somehow, the biker had snaked his way between the limo and the Yakuza car on the side. The biker’s gear was a vivid shade of red. It matched perfectly with his bike that was also the same shade. Running down the sides of the bike were thick black lines. To top it off, the helmet was the same color of red with a black visor.

On the biker’s back was a large black backpack and Izuku squinted when he felt like he saw some odd shape protrude from the material. Izuku stared longer than he meant to, and as if the biker could feel his eyes on him, slowly the biker turned his head.

He looked dead at Izuku.

Goosebumps formed along Izuku’s spine in a straight line. He reeled back from the window and his heart rate increased.

He stared at the biker and the biker stared at him.

An unspoken electricity surged in the air and suddenly Izuku grew confused. The biker revved his engine and tilted his head. The light turned green, and in a flash the mysterious biker took off. Izuku glanced at the license plate naturally and found it was unmarked.

Izuku furrowed his brow.

He stared after the biker that was swallowed up into the endless sea of traffic and neon lights.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When they reached the venue, it was something right out of a book.

Izuku was almost amazed by how lavish it was. Almost.

It was a popular ballroom venue that had bright, green lights illuminating the whole structure. The marble architecture of the building had old renaissance angels engraved into it.

Hundreds of people from the underground scene ambled about in masquerade attire. Everyone was waiting outside to get in but Izuku felt queasy for an unspoken reason.

When the limo pulled up to the front of the venue, Izuku immediately recognized some of the poorly covered faces. Most of the people here had strong political ties to the Yakuza. Or they were simply just Yakuza.

The driver opened the door and Chisaki and Tomura were the first to get out. Izuku waited until the bodyguards and assistant got out of the limo and then emerged.

Immediately when he stood up straight, all the level of chatting died down to whispers. Izuku looked up to see a sea of people gawking at him, Tomura and Chisaki.

Chisaki held his arm out for Izuku to hold. “Shall we?”

Izuku swallowed all his distaste and grabbed Chisaki's arm. He coyly smiled up at the man and Chisaki’s eyes lit up like fireworks.

Izuku glanced at his brother, and Tomura was giving them quiet approval. His shoulders were relaxed, and in his eyes danced a new found sense of control that wasn’t there before. Izuku’s heart was sinking steadily as he saw Tomura breathe in like he was already drunk on power.

Izuku was officially fearful of the future.

They began to walk into the venue, cutting the line.

Izuku noted how top notch the security was. Trained Yakuza guards were poised with guns all around the perimeter. They held fierce stares and sharp frowns as their cunning eyes scrutinized the crowd.

Izuku watched as one couple was turned away from the entrance. They burst into tears when their names failed to be on the provided guest list. They exclaimed that they were friends of the Governor, but it was no use. Security booted them off to the side and told them to get lost.

When Chisaki’s entourage made it inside, Izuku’s ears were graced with the lovely sound of violins.

They checked their coats in the front then made their way around. Several people stopped to talk to Chisaki and Tomura. Many of them wanted to be in their good graces. Everyone complimented Izuku for looking exquisite and told Chisaki he was a lucky man.

After a few conversations and having to force himself to drink a glass of red wine, the three of them began to walk to the center of the venue. They strolled up to the intricate golden railing next to the spiral staircase.

Izuku gawked at the dance floor down below.

It was jam packed full of people in their best formal masquerade attire. Women in dazzling gowns and diamonds fluttered across the marble floor while men strutted like peacocks. From high above, people in private boxes looked down and watched the orchestra play on the lit up stage. Every classical music instrument Izuku could think of was poised like a deity in the front of the large room.

Izuku curiously noted how everyone was wearing light colored neutrals only or all black. It must've been part of the dress code.

He was the only person wearing a pop of green.

Tomura then spun on his heels and turned to them with a rare smile.

"I'll leave you two alone for the rest of the night," Tomura said with ease. "If anything happens please feel free to call me. Otherwise, enjoy your time together."

Chisaki bowed politely to Tomura. "Of course. Thank you so much, Shigaraki."

Izuku could see the hint of glee spark in his brother's eyes at the recognition of his new name. Tomura turned to Izuku expectantly and Izuku politely bowed as well.

"Thank you, Big Brother," Izuku said quietly. "I'll see you soon."

Tomura nodded and spared them both one more glance before disappearing into the dense crowd. Izuku looked down at the people below and could see a couple looking up at him. They squinted as if trying to make sure he was who they thought.

"There's a lot of important people here," Izuku said offhandedly when he caught sight of the Governor. "I didn't think this much of a crowd would show up."

"Well, when one has managed to get their hands on Hadeus' beautiful Viridian Viper, they don't exactly keep it a secret. Do they?" Chisaki replied cheekily.

"I suppose not," Izuku muttered.

Chisaki laughed a bit and then began to lead them through the crowds. At a point, Chisaki laced their hands together, pulling Izuku in close to his side. They walked down the spiral stairs to the center of the floor together. As they descended, multiple people parted for Chisaki and bowed. They greeted Chisaki like he was royalty and they all regarded Izuku like he was a first place trophy.

They took to the floor and immediately began dancing to the alluring beautiful song.

Izuku and Chisaki gazes tethered to each other in the middle of the dance floor. They started a soft waltz in tandem with the rest of the glamorous crowd. Their heated eye contact was unmoving as they swayed with the rhythm.

Izuku knew Chisaki was imagining taking him apart in the bedroom. He could feel Chisaki daydream about what type of moans he would make or how he quivered with the right touch. In the same breath, Izuku imagined taking Chisaki apart too—but in one of the more grisly ways he could think of.

Limb by limb preferably.

Half way through the dance, Chisaki pulled Izuku close. Their chests pressed together and Izuku could feel the body heat gather between them.

"You know, I was very sad when you took that mission in Bangkok," Chisaki said. He continued to lead their dance without missing a beat. "My feelings were a little hurt to say the least. Usually people are jumping to get in bed with me. But you ran away to a different country, for *months*."

"Sorry," Izuku apologized. He steeled his nerves as he kept eye contact. "It wasn't anything personal Mr. Chi—I mean Kai. It was only business."

"So I was told."

That didn't sound like he was very much convinced.

"In the time you were away, I came to learn your brother Tomura is quite protective of you," Chisaki said, moving the conversation in a way he wanted. "Is this how he usually is?"

"Yes," Izuku replied. "He's been this way since we were young."

"I suppose that's a good thing. Family is important." Chisaki's eyes then lowered to Izuku's lips. "Does he usually control all your affairs?"

"Yes, he does. Tomura is very competent."

"Does this include who you date?"

"I—I'm not allowed to date without my brother's permission," Izuku said honestly.

"That's what I heard. But, after talking with your brother more, he tells me the reason why is because you don't *want* to date. Mainly because you're a hopeless romantic and find casual flings unappealing." Chisaki leaned in a bit. "Is that correct?"

"Ye-Yes," Izuku answered, stammering from the sudden strangeness in their conversation. Why had Tomura let his defect slip up to Chisaki of all people? "Th-That's correct."

“So, you must not be my biggest fan right now then. Considering the terms of our arrangement.”

By accident, Izuku stared at Chisaki in bewilderment then quickly fixed his expression. He skirted his eyes down. Chisaki twirled him in a large spin and Izuku found himself tongue-tied.

“You can be honest with me,” Chisaki teased. He smiled in an eerie manner as he pulled Izuku close to him once more. “I enjoy honesty from the people I go to bed with. Every day I have people surrounding me telling me what they *think* I want to hear. But I never really know people’s real intentions. So be truthful with me, Izuku. It’ll benefit you.”

Izuku slowly tilted his head away from the Yakuza heir, unsure of what exactly to say.

But when Chisaki’s grip on him grew almost painful, Izuku gave in.

“No,” Izuku bit out. “I’m not your biggest fan at the moment, Kai.”

Chisaki chuckled with a large, satisfied smirk. “You hate me, don’t you?”

“Yes,” Izuku whispered so low even he had a hard time hearing himself.

But Chisaki heard him. He heard him loud and clear because in the next second, he stopped dancing all together. He held Izuku close, and brought their lips an inch apart. His breath tickled Izuku’s mouth past the emerald tassels and the glint in his eyes amplified to new heights.

Izuku watched as a particular type of sadistic pleasure twisted inside of Chisaki’s smile.

“*Good*,” Chisaki whispered across Izuku’s skin. “I felt a little bad after learning you’re a hopeless romantic, admittedly. It suddenly all made sense why someone like you, who gets people thrown at your feet every day, was a virgin.”

Izuku felt Chisaki’s hand slide down the trail of buttons that lined his back. His hand stopped directly at the hem of his shirt and slowly began to knead small circles into his body.

“How about we make a deal,” Chisaki proposed. “I will try my best to make the next two weeks utterly romantic for you. And in exchange, you keep an open mind about seriously dating me after this.”

Chisaki might as well have barred his neck for Izuku to slash, because he exposed a weakness plain as day: he was romantically interested in Izuku.

Izuku’s eyes flickered with murderous intent. Luckily for him, Chisaki was too blinded by lust to see it.

“We would have to probably sneak around for that to happen,” Izuku whispered. He switched his demeanor and turned on his coy, seductive kill switch. “If my brother knew…” Izuku put on a show and shyly glanced over to where Tomura was across the ballroom chatting with a circle of people. “He would…try to instigate his terms.”

Chisaki's eyes followed Izuku's and glanced sideways at Tomura. Then he returned to gazing at Izuku with a devious smirk.

"That's possible," Chisaki said slyly. "I can arrange for us to have meetings no one else knows about."

"Really?" Izuku asked bashfully. "You would do that for me?"

"Of course. I've been waiting to get my hands on you for a long time. If there's any chance of you being mine outside of this arrangement, I will make that happen."

"Okay," Izuku said. "We have a deal then."

A perfect deal for Izuku to gain a discreet opening to kill Chisaki.

Izuku smiled sincerely in that moment, happy how easily that fell into his lap.

Chisaki looked more than satisfied too. His golden eyes peered down at Izuku full of promise for the future.

He lifted one hand with tender care. He brushed aside the emerald tassels that covered Izuku's mouth. Izuku's heart rate sped up as he saw the look in Chisaki's eyes dive further into carnal desire. His gaze went half lidded and the hand on the small of his back pressed flat.

"May I kiss you?" Chisaki asked.

Izuku nodded hesitantly and braced himself. He wrapped his arms around Chisaki's shoulders and Chisaki wrapped his arms around Izuku's waist.

Izuku fluttered his eyes closed and tried to let his mind wander.

When Chisaki's lips landed on his, Izuku pictured himself elsewhere. A beach, or even a coffee shop. But when the kiss forcefully deepened, it brought him back to the reality he couldn't escape.

It was sickening. Chisaki's tongue felt like a worm in his mouth.

Izuku screwed his eyes shut as he let the man in front of him take what he wanted. Izuku half kissed Chisaki back, trying to sell the under-experienced but willing persona his plan hinged on. Chisaki seemed ecstatic with Izuku's poor attempt to return the kiss.

He eagerly threaded his hand through Izuku's hair and took the lead.

As Chisaki continued to take and take, Izuku unwillingly compared the kiss to Katsuki's.

While Katsuki's kiss was as hot as fire, Chisaki's kiss was uncomfortably lukewarm. Katsuki always worked their mouths in tandem, while Chisaki forced his way in. Katsuki was perfectly in tune with his needs, while Izuku was unsure if Chisaki knew he had any. Izuku hated the way he smelled suffocating, expensive cologne instead of subtle cinnamon.

But most of all, Izuku missed the perfect coarseness of Katsuki's hands around his throat.

When they broke apart from the kiss all Izuku could think about was Katsuki.

His heartbreak re-emerged and dragged him down. He tried to ignore it but it doubled, then tripled. It transformed into a pile of broken bricks in his ribcage and the sharp edges cut him every time he moved.

It was overwhelming. Izuku missed Katsuki more than he could manage.

But Chisaki was staring at him with clouds of lust blinding his vision.

"How was that for a first kiss?" Chisaki arrogantly asked.

Izuku's eyes began to sting. "I-It was perfect."

Happy with that answer, Chisaki leaned in again. Izuku braced himself once more. But right as Chisaki was about to steal away another piece of Izuku's pride, he was stopped.

"Mr. Chisaki," One of the Yakuza bodyguards called out. The burly overly tattooed man came bum-rushing forward, pushing through the crowd. "We need you right away. There's an issue on the third floor."

A vein instantly popped in Chisaki's forehead. He turned his head slowly to his employee and narrowed his eyes.

"Can't you see I am a bit busy with my prize?" Chisaki dangerously warned.

"I know but this can't wait," The guard replied.

The guard leaned in and whispered something into Chisaki's ear. Izuku strained to hear it but was unable to. He only caught the single words of 'bodies' and 'upstairs'. Whatever was said, must have been urgent. All the lust drained from Chisaki's face and extreme seriousness enveloped him.

"Excuse me for a moment," Chisaki said to Izuku. He offered an apologetic smile and backed away. "This shouldn't take long."

He squeezed Izuku's hand affectionately before walking away with his guard towards the stairs.

Izuku watched as Chisaki disappeared into the dense crowd. People began curiously glancing between the two of them.

He caught Tomura's gaze from across the room and there was a potent amount of confusion stricken across his brother's face. Izuku shrugged, holding his hands up. Tomura sighed and quickly followed off to the direction Chisaki disappeared to.

As Izuku stood alone in the room of strangers, the sudden pain inside of his chest began to grow. It weighed him down, making gravity feel like it was tenfold. He touched his lips. The

kiss might as well have burned.

He was left feeling deeply violated and he wanted to peel the first layer of skin off his lips.

He tried to hold it in, but he became nauseated.

Izuku glanced around at the hundreds of prying eyes.

They picked at him and every whisper felt like a nick directly slashed into his skin. Without warning, Izuku's chest became uncomfortably tight. The lace around his neck grew itchy. Izuku breathed out as he tried to steady himself. But the walls of people around him felt like they were closing in, and it became terribly difficult to focus.

Izuku blinked rapidly and immediately his memory filled with Katsuki.

Katsuki's smile. His laugh. His voice. His haunting eyes. Izuku even swore he saw a blur of ash blond hair in the crowd coming towards him. That's when he knew he was going to lose it.

The sickness sitting inside of his stomach moved upwards.

"E-Excuse me," Izuku whispered to the person that was standing in his way.

Izuku pushed through the crowd with wobbly legs towards the back corner. His vision swelled as his heart rate picked up. His breaths became short and quick because everything felt too close. Izuku stumbled into the back of the large room where there were less people. He desperately leaned against one of the marble pillars that was shrouded in a bit of shadows.

He watched as the happy people on the dance floor continued about their lives. He was jealous of them. How lucky they were to seem so free and *willing* to be here. He gazed at one couple, watching them dance.

They melted into a vision of him and Katsuki swaying back and forth like they had on the boat in Okinawa. Izuku wanted that back. He wanted it back so badly.

He wanted his husband.

He leaned against the pillar fully and lowered his head. His eyes stung with tears as he thought about Katsuki. How had things gotten so messed up? Why hadn't he spoken the truth and they could have worked something out? Izuku's regrets nearly made him fall to his knees right there on the floor.

Then suddenly, a hand snaked its way around his throat from behind.

Izuku's tears stopped as did his breathing.

The calluses of the hand were in a pattern that Izuku knew by heart. He had felt this hand around his neck many times in many different ways. He knew the shape of it like his own

soul. It fit perfectly around his throat as it took its rightful place there like a king to a throne and squeezed until it hurt.

Izuku choked as he was yanked backwards. He was pressed flush against an all too familiar body.

Rough lips grazed the shell of his ear and that dangerously deep voice spoke.

“I found you, darling.”

Chapter End Notes

Kyuuka smiles at you as she buckles you into a car. She tests the straps of the seatbelt for security, making sure you can't get out. She ties your hand with two ropes that are labeled 'angst' and 'extra angst'. Then right as you're about to ask what's happening, she pushes the car right over the ledge of a cliff.

You scream as you tip over right over the steep drop.

((Thank you so much for reading!!)

Chapter 28: Dissonance

Chapter Summary

Dissonance (tempo modifier) lack of harmony among musical notes.

Chapter Notes

Helloooo! Welcome back to this very special chapter :) It's going to set the stage for this final section of the fic and all future chapters! I'm really stoked to have you guys read it! Going to jump right in because it's a doozy. Please regard the tags and warnings with seriousness!

Warnings: Graphic Depictions of Violence, Character Death, Darker themes

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 28 — Dissonance

.

.

.

The moment he heard ‘darling’ in that dangerous, raspy voice, Izuku’s heart fluttered.

It was an automatic reaction, primal almost. Like a call to bring him home to where he belonged. He felt instantly light on his feet with newfound butterflies tickling his stomach.

But Izuku’s second reaction was led with logic. He thought that his ears must have been deceiving him. He assumed his cruel brain was playing a trick, like it had many times before. Surely, his grief was causing him to hallucinate Katsuki like he hallucinated Hiryu.

But the figure pressed into his backside did not vanish. It did not fade. It stayed rooted in place, breathing in and out like a real person. Izuku’s vision vignetted as he craned his neck to stare behind him. Looming directly over him was the man of both his dreams and nightmares.

“K-Katsuki?” Izuku whispered in disbelief. His eyes began to stretch wide. “You—You’re here?”

Katsuki cocked his head at him and raised a brow. “I am.”

Izuku didn’t know what to say.

He was rendered speechless and all he could do was drop his mouth open.

His mind began to race a mile per minute. What was Katsuki doing here? Why hadn’t he called? How did he get into the building? How did he even know he would be *here*, of all places? But more so, how had he reacted to the letter? Is that why he was here? Did he come all this way to discuss everything inside of it?

No. He must’ve come here to discuss his mother. That would make the *most* sense.

As Izuku stared at Katsuki, a million questions burned into his head and he became dazed.

But a single whisper from beside them brought him back to reality.

Izuku glanced around at the hundreds of people on the dance floor. Some of them were still ignorantly flocking about. But others were studying him—specifically the crowd that was Yakuza. Izuku then sharply cut his eye to the sides of the room where the bodyguards were aligned. Many of them kept their eyes on him.

Or more specifically, they kept their eyes on him and *Katsuki*.

His stomach dropped to the ground and he snapped out of his daze all the way. It clicked then that this specific crowd was a recipe for disaster. Because the *second* Tomura or Chisaki came back and saw Katsuki, it would be like lighting a room full of dynamite.

Izuku turned around slowly and the grip on his throat went slack.

He tried to remain calm in order to not draw any more attention from the bodyguards. All of which were very much armed with loaded guns.

But it was hard, as tonight was the night meant for all eyes to be on him.

Out of his peripheral vision, Izuku saw a handful of Yakuza shift cautiously. Their eyes homed in on Katsuki when he stood closer to Izuku. It was here Izuku knew Chisaki must’ve given orders to make sure a mindful eye was kept on his ‘prize’ tonight.

Izuku thought fast on his feet. He cut his eyes down the vacant hallway around the corner. It was near the bathroom areas and void of prying eyes.

Running purely on instinct, Izuku grabbed Katsuki’s wrist.

“We can’t be seen together here,” Izuku whispered hastily. He jutted his head to the side where the hallway was. “Let’s go over there.”

Izuku tugged on Katsuki’s wrist and tried to lead them away.

But Katsuki stayed as still as a rock.

When Katsuki didn't budge, Izuku grew confused. He looked back towards Katsuki with a questioning glance. He pulled on him again, but was unable to move the sturdy man. Izuku nervously gazed up at the stairs, hoping that neither Tomura nor Chisaki came down them.

"K-Katsuki, seriously," Izuku said with added urgency. His eyes darted at all the people who were now staring at them. "We—we can talk but not here. We can't be seen together right now."

"Since when was it a crime to be seen with your *husband*?" Katsuki asked carefully, with a slight bite.

Izuku halted.

"Husband?" Izuku parroted. He looked at Katsuki sideways, thinking about the divorce papers he signed and delivered two weeks ago. "We're…We're still married?"

Katsuki glowered. "Of course we are."

Izuku barely had time to process that bit of information because the expression in Katsuki's face became alarming. His red eyes were illuminated with a dark flicker of light. They simmered on low heat and burned with an unmoving gaze.

Izuku let go of Katsuki's wrist when his gut told him something wasn't right.

It was here Izuku finally assessed Katsuki's appearance.

Katsuki was wearing the scarlet suit they picked out together a few months ago. It was slightly scuffed, and there was a subtle bulge peeking from the inside of his blazer. If someone got as close as Izuku was now, they could probably make it out to be several guns hiding inside of his blazer.

But more alarming, the black tie around his neck was stiff—like it was lined with a knife. And he was wearing a white porcelain mask that only covered one side of his face. It was cracked down the middle, leaving a jagged edge. Originally, Izuku thought the mask had small, decorative red spots on it.

But when one of the spots moved, dripping downwards to leave a trail, Izuku realized he was wrong.

It was fresh blood.

All the hairs on Izuku's body stood up.

"Why don't we have a dance, darling?" Katsuki asked in a lilting voice. He gestured behind him to the open floor. "I've always wanted to dance with you properly."

Katsuki gently held out a hand for Izuku to take, tempting him.

But Izuku continued to stare at him sideways.

He couldn't place it, but his intuition was telling him this felt wrong. Almost as if the ground beneath his feet tilted ever so slightly, leaving him a little unbalanced. Izuku nervously peaked around and saw several people looking at them.

He glanced up at the stairs once more. He decided the sooner he gave Katsuki what he wanted, the sooner he could get them out of sight.

He reached for Katsuki's hand and immediately their fingers laced together.

Izuku tripped a bit as Katsuki pulled him close. Slowly, Katsuki began to backtrack to the center of the floor. They stopped at the exact spot where Izuku was moments ago with Chisaki. Once they made it to the center of the room, Izuku felt bizarre.

There were so many questions Izuku wanted to blurt out. But he didn't get a chance as Katsuki began a dizzying tango.

They kept their gazes tethered as they swayed, pulling close. The rush of body heat and intimacy blossomed between them as they locked stealthy, cat-like steps. Katsuki's eyes drank him in. Izuku looked at him right back as Katsuki's hand raked the curve of his back. They whirled, not breaking eye contact and then Katsuki dipped him low, almost to the ground.

Izuku couldn't help but swoon.

But then Katsuki's eyes grew more intense. As he lifted him up he asked, "Did you know all along you were the one who killed my mother, Izuku?"

Izuku stumbled in his dance steps. His heart raced faster and his fingers became clammy. He knew his letter did not *exactly* explain how he found out about the murder. He only wrote that he wasn't aware of who she was.

"No," Izuku answered honestly. His heart became heavy with guilt and he sadly looked into his love's unreadable gaze. "I didn't know the whole time—"

"—Then how long *did* you know?" Katsuki asked.

Izuku tried his best to keep up with Katsuki as he changed the pace. But Katsuki was now making sharp movements hard enough to make Izuku dizzy. Everything immediately blurred in a blend of bland colors as he was whipped around and around.

"I found out the night you went to retire," Izuku whispered.

At this, Katsuki's unreadable expression flipped. True hurt spread across his beautiful features. It stuck so deep that Izuku knew it would never leave.

"You knew for the entire last *month* we were living together?" Katsuki whispered angrily. "And you didn't think to tell me?"

He slowed their dance and all the blurred surroundings came back into focus. Izuku looked around, dazed and dizzy. He cut his wobbly eyes up to the stairs and luckily found no sign of

Chisaki or Tomura.

But his anxiety spiked when he realized all the guards were looking at them now.

Izuku swallowed.

“I…I was going to. B-But I was too afraid,” Izuku confessed. He was acutely aware of how useless a ‘sorry’ was in this moment. His own expression crumbled and the ache in his chest begged to ease Katsuki’s heartbreak. “I wanted to. *I did*—I couldn’t find a way to come out and say it. I’m so sorry Katsuki. I’m really *really* sorry for everything. If I could take back what I did, I would. I didn’t know it was her. I-I swear. I know that doesn’t excuse anything.”

The groveling didn’t seem to reach Katsuki all the way. There was a wall of hurt around him that was nearly unbreakable.

“You’re right. You’re pathetic sorrys don’t excuse anything.” Katsuki’s pained expression dived into a level of untapped anger. “Why didn’t you just fucking tell me instead of letting me believe it was Chizome?”

“Because I was scared of hurting you,” Izuku admitted honestly.

Katsuki’s raw expression twisted with a snarl. His chin lowered menacingly and the mask on his face nearly slipped off.

“Bullshit,” Katsuki snapped. “Bull fucking *shit*. If you cared about hurting me, you wouldn’t have had that *scum’s* tongue down your throat five seconds ago and who knows however many times now.”

It was like being backhanded. Izuku’s eyes widened, feeling undoubtedly hurt that Katsuki would throw something that wasn’t his choice in his face. He *told* him. He had explained the Chisaki deal very well in his letter; he was sure. But the fury in Katsuki’s eyes continued to blend with unbridled jealousy.

“Now. Let’s try that again. Why did you not tell me, Izuku?” Katsuki demanded.

“Because I was scared,” Izuku whispered, holding back tears. “That’s the truth.”

“But of *what*?” Katsuki demanded, raising his voice.

At the sharp volume, Izuku unwillingly flinched.

And immediately Katsuki stopped dancing all together.

With that single flinch, a revelation dawned on Katsuki. His menacing scowl fell to the ground. In its place was only the look of a sad, misunderstood human. Katsuki silently stared at Izuku in disbelief.

“You were scared…of *me*,” Katsuki whispered so low Izuku strained to hear it. “Did you think I would hurt you if you told me? Even after everything?”

Yes, was the answer that automatically came to Izuku's mind. But it wasn't said in his voice. It was said in Tomura's. He paused, and his thoughts flashed back to Tomura's warnings. Then his thoughts flashed through all of his and Katsuki's precious moments. Specifically the time in the nursery.

And in that moment, Izuku's biggest mistake became crystal clear. Hindsight was truly 20/20 and Izuku saw his worst miscalculation up close now.

Katsuki leaned away from Izuku, shocked at the lack of denial.

His eyes darted all around Izuku's face as he filled in the blanks. Soon, Izuku's silence was enough of an answer. Katsuki's expression crumbled into heartbreak the longer the silence stretched on.

When Katsuki's eyes became glossy with tears, Izuku wanted to reverse time.

Tomura's noxious warning had gotten in the way of his better judgment. His brother's manipulative words twisted the one fact Izuku always thought to be true: Katsuki was soft with him.

Of course Katsuki wouldn't have hurt him if he'd been upfront with the truth. Katsuki valued honesty and Katsuki said he *trusted* Izuku right in front of his mother's grave. He opened up about his painful past and confided in Izuku how he was feared by so many people in his life. He was feared by his friends. His coworkers. His supervisor.

Even Katsuki's own mother had been afraid of him.

But the only person who wasn't was Izuku.

Izuku made sure Katsuki knew he could be soft. Izuku took Katsuki's hands and showed him they were capable of more than reaping blood. He embraced all bits of Katsuki, even the darkest parts.

But now, with the help of Tomura, Izuku accidentally stabbed Katsuki directly in his most vulnerable insecurity.

"No," Izuku said rapidly to cover up his dire mistake. He began shaking his head furiously as the hurt in Katsuki's eyes became so overpowering he felt it in his soul. "No. No, Katsuki. I-I'm so sorry I didn't think that at all—"

But it was too late. Katsuki's hurt morphed into something truly fearsome in that moment.

It grew winged armor, fangs, and shrouded itself in the anger Katsuki always used to protect himself. A single tear drop fell out of Katsuki's eye and took all his reasoning with it. In its wake, the tear left behind a dark leer crafted of violent jealousy and depravity.

"You did," Katsuki said in a deep, steady voice. More tears fell. "You're scared of me. Because I'm a *monster*, right?"

Izuku's heart nearly flatlined.

Katsuki's eyes darkened and Izuku felt the wall of anger go to new heights. There was no reaching Katsuki now. His eyes narrowed and Izuku watched as his pupils constricted down into tiny dots.

All that was left in his eyes was an unnatural amount of scarlet.

"You were scared enough to *poison* me so I wouldn't be able to hurt you," Katsuki continued. With every accusatory word he spoke, hate gathered in his tone like a tsunami. "And then you came running to Tokyo for protection from me in Yakuza scum's arms. But worse of all, you went and cuddled up with the man who requested my mother's murder without a goddamn shred of decency."

The words strangled him in the face and he shook his head more.

He tried to ignore the way Katsuki's hold on him was growing more and more intense.

"No," Izuku exclaimed past his wincing. "N-No! That's not what this is at all. I told you in my—"

Izuku yelped out loud when Katsuki's fingernails tore through the material of his blazer. The sharp tips sunk into his skin, drawing blood. Izuku's heart dropped and he tried to move backwards away from Katsuki. But it was no use. Katsuki's grip was as strong as an iron fist.

Izuku's warning senses began to go off like blaring alarms.

He wildly looked over at the guards who were now walking towards them. All the guards put their hands to their waistbands, reaching for their guns.

"K-Katsuki. People are watching," Izuku begged. "This isn't the place to do this. There's too many Yakuza members here. They will *kill* you."

"They can try," Katsuki replied callously. His eyes glazed over with vengeance. "Because if everyone in the world thinks I'm a monster, then *fine*." Katsuki's mouth curled. "I'll give them the bloodiest monster they've ever seen."

Izuku looked into Katsuki's eyes, and his blood ran cold. His Kacchan was no longer reachable.

In his place stood The Scarlet Eyed Killer .

"Hey, you!" One guard yelled out. He grabbed Katsuki by his shoulder and forcefully spun him around. "What do you think you're doing—"

The guard didn't have the chance to finish his sentence.

All of Katsuki's killer reflexes clicked into place at that moment to show his full throttle form. With unnerving speed, Katsuki reached into his blazer, pulled out a loaded gun, and aimed it directly between the guard's eyes. He pulled the trigger before the next word could even be uttered.

Blood splattered across both Izuku's and Katsuki's faces.

Horrified, shrill shrieks erupted all around the room.

Katsuki's bone chilling gaze sliced towards Izuku. In the reflection of his eyes, Izuku could see Mitsuki's death echo. It was here Izuku knew there would be no reasoning with Katsuki right now—but he also knew he couldn't die.

Not before Katsuma was safe.

Immediately, Izuku took the defensive.

He snatched his body away from Katsuki as Katsuki whirled his gun on him.

Izuku ducked into the stampede of people as protection and bullets began raining down like hail. People surrounding him screamed out as they were shot. One man dropped straight to the ground, dead. His body was lost to the crowd as hundreds of people stepped on him to flee.

Multiple hands began pulling on Izuku. He whirled around in the chaos to see four Yakuza guards on him. They surrounded him in a tight formation and forced him to duck behind them. They shot back at Katsuki but Katsuki moved with an unnatural speed. It was as if his feet were being carried by his fury.

Katsuki shot down person after person, trying to clear a path to Izuku.

All the Yakuza body guards came flying out from around the corners with rifles. They shoved people out of their way as they began unloading. Katsuki gritted his teeth and his eyes became violently wild as he went on the defensive. He ducked behind a pillar as they surrounded him, but his aim remained true.

He landed multiple kill-shots with formidable accuracy.

The Yakuza guards surrounding Izuku dragged him through the stream of people attempting to flee. They went straight for the stairs, trying to get him to safety.

One guard looked at Izuku seriously as he shoved him up the stairs. "We need to get you out the building—"

But then a bullet cut clean through the guard's skull.

His eyes rolled back and Izuku became soaked with his blood.

Three more bullets drove through the air and landed in the other three guards' skulls. Izuku's heart dropped as he toppled to the ground with the weight of the dead bodies. One body twitched on top of him, pouring out blood from the wound.

All the guests began desperately climbing over him towards the exit. Izuku hissed out loud when one person stepped on his hand and several others stepped on his back.

He looked up terrified as he was beginning to be left behind. Izuku stayed low to the ground, allowing himself to be trampled. He protected his head from too much injury as a new wave of cries filled the room with several more gunshots.

When the worst of the thick crowd felt like it passed, Izuku crawled up the stairs. He used the body on top of him as a shield as he stayed low, careful not to be seen by Katsuki. When he made it to the top, he was covered in blood and bruises.

His whole body shook with terror as he glanced down at the dance floor.

Katsuki was going toe to toe with ten more guards.

His husband's movements were as sharp as his killer gaze.

He absorbed all the hits like he was made of concrete. His punches and kicks were backed by all his overwhelming strength.

He slammed one guard into a pillar, cracking his skull. He then broke another's wrist in a twisted dance. Following that, Katsuki snapped one man's neck with a quickness and then stabbed another in the heart in a continuous, fluid motion.

Izuku had never witnessed this level of brutality from Katsuki. But from this distance, Izuku could see it was beckoned forward by revenge.

Katsuki was collecting the blood toll for what happened to his mother.

Izuku crawled on the carpeted floor and shakily stood up. He quickly moved, using the railing for balance. His heart pounded in his chest as his head throbbed.

His instincts went into overdrive to survive. He needed to keep pushing forward for Katsuma.

People shoved him out the way in a fury of movements. Izuku stumbled on his feet as his shoulder was savagely pushed. All around in the chaos, the well dressed people scattered like frantic ants. Some ran for the door. Other's ran for hallways. Some even began trying to climb out the window.

Izuku took one more glance down at the dance floor.

He caught sight of the last man being killed by Katsuki. Katsuki slammed a vase over his head, then cut the man's throat with a precise slash of his blade.

Izuku recognized the blade in Katsuki's hand.

It was the one engraved with his mother's name into the handle.

The body dropped to the ground, leaving Katsuki as the last man standing. He lingered in the middle of endless dead bodies catching his breath. They circled around him, covering the floor. Where there was not a cold limb there was blood.

In that horrible stillness, Izuku understood. He could vividly see what Katsuki's purpose was: he was born to paint the world in deep shades of scarlet. Whether that red was from love, passion, or blood—that was still unknown.

Katsuki's murderous eyes cut up to Izuku.

They locked stares.

Without breaking eye contact, Katsuki cracked his neck. He took off the porcelain mask to fully reveal his terrifyingly handsome face that was doused in wrath. He discarded the fragile item to the ground, and it shattered upon impact.

He shrugged off his blazer to unveil a hidden holster of loaded guns and knives.

Izuku immediately ran and Katsuki began to chase after him.

Izuku hightailed it for the exit with his pulse pounding in his ears. He ran as fast as he could but when he rounded the corner, he came to a skidding halt.

He caught sight of Tomura and several dozen more Yakuza bodyguards. They were running towards the exit too from the opposite direction.

Izuku's limbs went cold when he saw the murderous look on his brother's face. Tomura's eyes were set at subzero, scanning the chaotic crowd for the culprit. In his hands was a long rifle, locked and loaded.

Izuku snapped his head to look behind him.

He could see Katsuki cutting through the crowd coming directly for him. He was shooting down Yakuza member after Yakuza member that tried to stop him.

"Shit," Izuku cursed.

He backtracked and ran away from the exit, leading Katsuki away from Tomura.

He dodged several bullets from Katsuki that cut through the air and landed in the walls. Izuku did his best to steer Katsuki away from the exit and deeper into the venue. With quick speed, he sharply cut down one grand hallway that was empty. It was filled with several other banquet halls and aligning the golden walls were large paintings and mirrors.

Izuku glanced behind him to see Katsuki running right on his heels, reloading his gun.

Then suddenly the lights cut off. Sirens bounced off every wall and red, danger alarms began flashing.

Izuku heard distant yells and he knew the building was going into a lockdown. The Yakuza were about to do what they did best. They were about to hunt down who was responsible. No one would be allowed to leave until the person was captured.

Izuku ran through the hallway faster. He picked up his speed, knowing Katsuki was always heavier and slower. The flashing red lights barely illuminated the way as his eyes hastily darted around. His lungs were set ablaze as he tried to think on his feet.

He cut down another hallway and came to a flight of stairs. Izuku flew up them at record speed to the second floor. He weaved in and out of different hallways, going deeper and deeper. He sharply ran down one hallway, and was met with a dead end with only a single door.

Katsuki's footsteps were closing in as Izuku tried to unlock the door.

But the door didn't budge. Izuku rattled the handle desperately.

He heard Katsuki get closer and Izuku rapidly shifted his approach. He bluntly threw his shoulder against the door with all his weight. The wood shook. He did it again and again, until he broke open the door with pure strength.

He tumbled inside the room the same second blistering pain sunk into him. Izuku yelled in agony as a bullet cut clean through his upper arm.

He fell inside the room, and gasps echoed out.

Izuku swiftly lifted his head to see a room full of at least twenty people in formal attire. They all had their guns pointed at the door. But the second they saw him, they lowered their weapons.

Some of the people were dark haired with golden eyes but others were clearly Yakuza body guards. The guards had rifles strapped to their backs and menacing leers. Off to the side were plates of food and a game of darts, as if they were enjoying their own private party before the chaos.

Izuku moved to get up on his feet and grabbed his arm where he was bleeding.

Katsuki fired off more bullets at him and Izuku stumbled as several nicked him. The people in the room began to scatter when Katsuki came into view, gun blazing. Izuku ran further into the private suite when he saw the Yakuza guards reach for their rifles.

Izuku dived for the back room when discord broke out.

He wildly searched for an exit as a cacophony of yelling erupted behind him. He could hear bullets, smashing and fighting occur at deafening octaves. Izuku knew he didn't have much time. He ran towards the window. He stumbled to unlock it when pain shot up his arm from where he had been shot.

Izuku hoisted up the window and the cold, winter air smothered him. It cooled down his sweaty skin as he climbed out of the window and onto the fire escape.

The wind howled and rocked the metal structure. Izuku stood on the rustic ledge, balancing himself delicately. He looked down below, and from up here he could see everything. There

was a small crowd of people who made it out before the doors locked. Dozens of police cars were gathered about but worse—Izuku could see Jin and Ibara slithering down below.

Abruptly, the gunfire behind him stopped.

No screams. No sounds.

Mortified, Izuku glanced over his shoulder.

Katsuki emerged from the darkness like he was crafted from shadows. In his hands was one of the Yakuza's rifles, and his face was sprayed with blood. The scarlet colored alarms blinked on and off, highlighting his razor sharp cheekbones. To Izuku, Katsuki looked stunning in the worst way. Like a crimson stained angel of death who was prepared to hunt him to the ends of the earth.

Katsuki's scarlet gaze locked on Izuku and he aimed the barrel right at him.

Izuku began to climb up the fire escape with haste as bullets flew past him. Running on pure adrenaline, he flung himself up several stairs at a time. The zing of bullets slamming into the metal fire escape reached his ears and made his heart pump quicker and quicker.

From the ground level, he heard someone yell, "Up there!"

On instinct, Izuku glanced down as he ran upwards. From this vantage point, he could see Jin pointing above, directly at Katsuki. Katsuki began climbing the fire escape and chased right behind Izuku.

Ibara's face sunk into a serious gaze. She swiftly took out her cellphone and began to make a call.

Unexpectedly, a third body crawled out of the window. It was one of the Yakuza guards, covered in blood and holding his stomach. He aimed his gun directly at Katsuki and fired off several bullets.

Katsuki staggered, getting nicked in the process. He ignored the man as he forged forward to follow behind Izuku.

When Izuku climbed onto the roof, he looked around desperately.

His brain began forming quick connections. At lightning speed, he pieced together a solution that would keep Katsuki *out* of Viper grasps. Tomura would snap Katsuki's neck if he saw him. And who knows what Chisaki would do if he recognized him.

Izuku whirled his head to the side and there, he saw his solution.

Towards the back were three, large rooftop exhaust vents. They were gooseneck shaped, and big enough to each fit a body. As Izuku's idea formed, the sound of bullets cut into his ear drums. He looked behind him to see pure madness.

Katsuki and the Yakuza guard were gridlocked in a tumultuous tussle.

This bodyguard was bigger than the others. He was more muscular than Katsuki with a tattoo of a spider web over his eye. He landed several sharp punches to Katsuki's jaw, which Katsuki ate with a grit of his teeth. Izuku staggered backwards as they swiftly began a deadly exchange of knives and punches.

But Katsuki's exhaustion was beginning to show. His breathing was harder and his hands were slightly shaking. His precision was slipping, creating sloppier blows. And this was all his opponent, who still possessed all this energy, needed.

Unknowingly, Katsuki gave the bodyguard an opening. In the blink of an eye, the bodyguard grappled for Katsuki. He picked Katsuki up and slammed him on the ground with terrifying strength. Katsuki choked and spit up blood. His eyes bulged and Izuku's protective senses went off seeing the red liquid drip from Katsuki's lips.

The bodyguard grappled for Katsuki again.

He dragged him to the edge and prepared to throw Katsuki off the roof.

Right as he lifted Katsuki up, Izuku's body moved. Izuku raced forward, shoulder butting the larger man. Izuku bit the inside of his cheek to get through the pain in his throbbing arm. He used all his strength to shove the man off of Katsuki.

This caught the bodyguard by surprise. He slipped and with a single yell, fell over the side of the building instead.

A bloodcurdling splat echoed out when he hit the bottom.

Izuku whirled on Katsuki who was now coughing up blood and holding his side. He looked in pain as his face scrunched and he groaned. Instinctively, Izuku kneeled down. He reached to help Katsuki with his wounds. But, before he could get close, Katsuki grabbed for his knife.

Izuku saw the glint of the metal in enough time to lean back. The tip of the blade grazed Adam's apple lightly and all the dread in Izuku's gut surged forward.

Katsuki really was trying to kill him.

"Katsuki!" Izuku screamed out as he dodged more attempts to gash his neck. "*Wait*!"

He scrambled backwards as Katsuki pushed forward.

The look in Katsuki's eyes was cold now, like he would never return from the depths of his malevolence.

Izuku stood up and so did Katsuki. He swung on Izuku and Izuku ducked under his arm. While twisting his body in a twirl, Izuku struck several pressure points on Katsuki's side. This made Katsuki seize up briefly. But the anger inside of him controlled his movements like he was being possessed.

Katsuki grabbed for the very last handgun in his holster and cocked it.

“Katsuki! Please, wait a moment!” Izuku yelled more when Katsuki began to fire off the gun.

To defend against him, Izuku stayed closely pressed to Katsuki’s back. This was done in order to not give Katsuki a clear shot. He stayed hidden in Katsuki’s blind spot as Katsuki kept trying to whirl around.

“*Please,* Katsuki! We-We can talk—”

“Shut up!” Katsuki viciously yelled. “I don’t give a fuck what you have to say! After I kill you I’m going to gut your new boyfriend and make you both pay for what you did to my *mother*!”

Katsuki reached behind him and grabbed Izuku’s arm. With all his strength, he flung Izuku in front of him and pulled the trigger.

Izuku shrieked as a hot bullet landed in his leg this time. He harnessed all the adrenaline in his blood to dodge the next few shots. He fought his way back to close range with agile maneuvering. Once he was back to hand to hand combat with Katsuki, Izuku decided it was time to put an end to this before Tomura appeared and killed them both.

Izuku and Katsuki began to dance again, but this time it was an exchange of deadly intent.

Every movement was blurred with their lightning quick speed. Each punch and kick Katsuki gave, Izuku blocked like they were in an off kilter waltz. He ducked, twirled, and twisted Katsuki’s limbs.

Then Katsuki tried to grab for his face, but instead got a fist full of the emerald tassels on Izuku’s mask. Izuku yanked backwards, and the mask broke. Tiny, pretty gems scattered to the ground and the forgotten mask fell to the floor.

Izuku cursed. He dove into advanced defensive techniques. He tried harder to make sure Katsuki didn’t get a grasp on him. He knew this fight would be over in a second if Katsuki pinned him. Katsuki’s strength was not something Izuku could easily counter.

Izuku reluctantly ramped up his fighting and was finally able to wrap his hand around Katsuki’s wrist. He kept it in a tight, binding hold. Katsuki tried to shake him off by twirling him several times.

They locked brutal, fiery glares.

Izuku forced the angle of Katsuki’s wrist to bend unnaturally. Every time Katsuki tried to aim and shoot him, Izuku maneuvered Katsuki’s wrist and made each bullet land anywhere but in him.

Izuku counted down until Katsuki was finally out of bullets.

When the final bullet failed to land in him, Izuku wrangled Katsuki’s arm with both hands. Using both his speed and strength, Izuku pulled Katsuki’s arm backwards. He did this until he felt Katsuki’s shoulder pop out of its socket.

Katsuki screamed, and Izuku screwed his eyes shut to drown it out.

Without skipping a beat, Izuku disarmed the gun from Katsuki with the twist of his wrist. Then he hit Katsuki in the side of the head with the blunt end of the weapon twice.

Katsuki stumbled. He gasped and grappled for Izuku.

Izuku gritted his teeth with tears pushing at his eyes. He powered through his heavy heart to hit Katsuki in the head once more, using all his strength.

The final blow landed with a hard crack and knocked Katsuki out cold.

All the roaring rage came to a halt, like water being thrown onto an open fire. Katsuki fizzled out, and the whiplash of the sudden silence made Izuku choke.

Katsuki's arms dropped to his sides. He slumped to the ground in a hard thud.

Izuku panted as he dropped the gun and fell to his knees next to Katsuki.

All the pain he was holding back washed over him in an instant. Everything in his body was lit on fire, down to his bones. His arm and leg throbbed around the lead inside of him. His head was pounding and he could barely hear anything past the coursing blood in his veins.

He wearily glanced at Katsuki's unconscious face in horror.

But before Izuku could process what happened, he heard footsteps coming up from below.

Quickly, Izuku stood up and gathered the gun. He stumbled on his feet, swaying with the wind. He leaned down and expertly popped Katsuki's shoulder back into place. He knew that it would be swollen later and hated himself for how he continually hurt Katsuki so much.

With the strength he had left, Izuku gritted his teeth and dragged Katsuki's body over to the large, metal vents. He grabbed a hold of the gate on it and ripped it off. Izuku gathered Katsuki in his arms and tried his best to lift him.

Katsuki was heavier than he imagined. It took a great deal of effort to hoist him up, and Izuku nearly failed. But he pushed through because he *had* to.

Through his tears, Izuku managed to put Katsuki in the vent legs first. He winced when Katsuki's body dropped inside clumsily like a rag-doll. He hit the ground of the vent, a metal gate that was securely attached. Izuku tossed the gun in too, and it landed on Katsuki's folded lap.

Next, Izuku took off his blazer and placed it over Katsuki's figure inside the dark vent. He covered him up well enough so no one would see anything but darkness if they walked by.

Then Izuku picked up the gate and put it back and place, locking Katsuki inside temporarily. He had no doubt Katsuki would get out of here the moment he woke up. But at least this way he would be kept safe from the Yakuza and Vipers if he stayed unconscious long enough.

Izuku stumbled back to the other side of the roof. Immediately, his knees buckled and he fell to the ground. He curled up on the cold concrete when his bullet wounds began to sting. He lowered his head and his erratic heart made his arms shake.

He made it just in time.

The door to the roof kicked open and out poured Tomura and a handful of bodyguards. They were armed and ready, pointing the barrel of guns all around the rooftop.

Tomura stalked over to Izuku and yanked him up to his feet by his shirt. Izuku winced and it was here that Tomura finally saw his bullet wounds.

The glare Tomura gave him was paralyzing.

“Where is the fucker who did this?!” One of the Yakuza yelled. His eyes were burning with fury as he whirled on Izuku. “We got a call that the culprit was chasing you up to the rooftop.”

“He—He got away,” Izuku panted out. He grabbed his arm and tried to slow the bleeding. “He jumped to the next rooftop that way.”

Izuku pointed in the opposite direction of the vents. Across from this rooftop, there was another building that was in range. It was believable enough that someone who was highly skilled could make the leap.

Everyone’s eyes turned to look at the other rooftop and one of the Yakuza cursed under his breath.

“And you didn’t think to *catch* him?” Tomura seethed. He narrowed his eyes at Izuku.

“He was too heavily armed,” Izuku deflected. He lowered his eyes, hoping the lie wasn’t too obvious. “I didn’t have anything on me to fight back. I needed to fend for myself the best I could, and I think I scared him off but that’s all I could accomplish.”

Tomura’s glare dug into him, seemingly unconvinced. He knew Izuku had more than enough skills to apprehend a single assailant, no matter how heavily armed. But when the Yakuza men began making calls and repeating what Izuku had said, he let it go. For now.

The Yakuza men began their pursuit in the wrong direction and Tomura grabbed Izuku by the nape. Izuku’s shoulders crept up at the controlling hold but he allowed his brother to steer him down the rooftop.

Izuku resisted the urge to look back at the vent.

His gut sank to new lows as they left, leaving Katsuki hidden in the dark.

ᔓᔓᔓ

“What the *hell* do you mean no one caught the shooter?” Chisaki shouted.

“I-I don’t know,” one of Chisaki’s men replied. His weary face was astonished as he stood in the middle of the room. “We tried searching for him but he was g-gone. We couldn’t find where he went.”

Izuku kept his head down.

They were all at The Viper Academy, in the lowest floor of the basement. The Academy was the closest Yakuza associated safe-hold to the venue. So, Chisaki demanded everyone be given sanctuary here until this mess was figured out.

The room they were in was large enough to fit about twenty people.

In this deepest floor of the Academy, the rooms were made of concrete and so were the hallways. No light could get in. It was a long string of connected hallways that was composed of various, barren rooms.

Growing up, this is where punishments were held. But because there hadn’t been a large cohort in so long, these rooms were now repurposed for private meetings and holding chambers.

Izuku was leaning against the wall next to Ibara.

She tended to his bullet wounds. Everyone else around them was deathly silent.

Across the room stood Chisaki, the few guards who somehow lived, and some of the other Yakuza members in Chisaki’s entourage.

On the other side of the room were the Vipers. Tomura leaned against the wall with his arms folded and Jin was eerily silent as well. Himiko, Aoyama, and several lower ranked Vipers were in the room too. They had been called in for added protection in case the mysterious killer possessed enough gall to follow them.

Tomura was examining Izuku with an unreadable expression.

Izuku remained as still as a corpse.

He barely could look at anyone in the room. His once beautiful outfit was ruined. Blood was matted into the lace and there were holes in his pants and blouse from where Katsuki shot him. Bruises from being trampled on were marked up and down his face and he had a busted lip.

“No one leaves this place until we find who is responsible,” Chisaki commanded as he paced around. “And I mean *no one*.”

Izuku had never seen him like this. The usually apathetic man was now brimming with hatred.

He kept his heated gaze locked on his Yakuza men. All of which kept their heads down, clearly ashamed.

“I lost five family members tonight. *Five*!” Chisaki shouted at his men. “My cousins, my aunt, and uncles from my father’s side are all *dead*! And no one could even bring me a *semblance* of the killer?!”

He paced as he began to bite at his fingernails.

“That man must have come with a vendetta to slaughter my family,” Chisaki whispered scornfully. “He somehow found the private room they were in within a mere matter of minutes. Not only that, he killed forty of my best men. *Forty*. And several guests! How is it possible that this man killed about fifty people and then escaped?!”

“I suspect he received inside help,” One of the Yakuza men with brown hair answered. “Someone must’ve let him in and then told him where your family was in the building.”

Chisaki bit his nail down to the stub. “That makes sense. We need to find the traitor—*tonight*. Shigaraki, do you have databases and computers down here that we could use?”

Tomura tore his gaze away from Izuku.

He shifted upright and cleared his throat. “We do. They’re around the corner. Aoyama can assist in showing you the equipment if you need.”

“Perfect,” Chisaki said. He looked expectantly at four of his Yakuza men and then mockingly gestured towards the door with his hands. “Well? What are you standing there for?”

The four all hurried out of the room. Aoyama followed behind them quietly at a quick pace.

“I’m going to go make some private calls to the rest of my family,” Chisaki announced angrily. He turned on his heels and snapped his fingers. His assistant materialized at his side. “I’ll be back in a moment. But no one leaves in or out of this basement until that *fucker* is found.”

Chisaki left the room as his assistant handed him his cell phone.

All the Vipers and the few Yakuza who remained looked at each other. They began to pick up in conversation, discussing the absolute mayhem that occurred. It’d been a while since that amount of bloodshed was done by anyone who was not the Yakuza. Much less on Yakuza territory.

As everyone discussed their theories, Izuku was stuck frozen knowing the truth.

Katsuki hadn’t come there for Chisaki’s family. He came there for Izuku and Chisaki themselves. Izuku accidentally led Katsuki to that room in his attempt to keep him far away from Tomura.

He touched the shallow cut on his Adam’s apple. It was where Katsuki’s blade almost sliced him. He tried his best to process what happened, but the truth was horrifying.

Katsuki tried to kill him.

He tried to kill him because Izuku broke his heart. He tried to kill him because he thought Izuku betrayed him. He tried to kill him because Izuku let Tomura convince him of the worst. Izuku held back tears as he relived the way Katsuki cried right before diving off the deep end.

He closed his eyes solemnly. Izuku blamed no one but himself.

Not even Katsuki.

He should have never listened to Tomura, that was now evident. This cracked his concrete belief that Tomura always knew best. Because for the first time ever, Tomura got it wrong. *Lethally* wrong. If Izuku led with his first instinct and told Katsuki the truth upfront, none of this would have happened.

When Ibara finished wrapping him up, Izuku thanked her quietly. She smiled and sighed.

“Sorry your special night with Chisaki got ruined by drama,” Ibara muttered. She patted him on the shoulder lightly. “I’m sure you’ll get a redo once this is all sorted out. He really likes you, y’know. I doubt he’ll let anything get in the way from you two being together. He’s been looking forward to it for so long.”

Before Izuku could respond to her, Tomura walked over and grabbed Izuku by his elbow. He wordlessly dragged him out the room, ignoring all the other people who stared after them.

Izuku could guess what was about to happen. They turned down two hallways out of ear shot. Tomura peered around, making sure they were alone before speaking.

“The description of the killer was blond hair and red eyes,” Tomura whispered firmly. “And there are a handful of witnesses who are saying that they saw him talking with *you* right before he began killing everyone.”

Izuku didn’t say a word.

“Did you tell Bakugou you and Chisaki were the ones who killed his mother?” Tomura questioned. “Like I said not to for this *exact* goddamn reason?”

“No. I didn’t say anything,” Izuku whispered. “I didn’t speak a word to him.”

He kept himself calm in his loophole of truth. But Tomura narrowed his eyes, clearly not believing him.

“You better hope for both your sake and mine, they find nothing that ties you to him,” Tomura said in a low, serious whisper. “Otherwise Chisaki is going to start demanding heads. *Our* heads.”

Izuku swallowed.

He glanced to the side wearily. This was a horribly sticky situation. But at the forefront of his mind were the children. Discord was about to happen and they would not be safe soon.

They returned to the room and Izuku thought quietly about Katsuma.

ᔓᔓᔓ

They weren't allowed to go anywhere.

The Yakuza stayed posted in front of the door, watching them all with untrusting eyes. And more so, because of the deaths in Chisaki's family, the consummation was once again postponed. The Yakuza had tossed his overnight duffle bag in the corner off to the side.

They sat in the room for hours waiting for Chisaki's posse to figure out who it was.

By now, all the Vipers sat down at chairs and gathered around the two tables in the room. Tomura was dead silent, typing on his phone sending emails. Izuku and Aoyama sat quietly next to each other. And off to the side, Jin, Ibara and Himiko were all talking about what happened. They gossiped about texts they were receiving from others in the Underground scene.

Apparently, people were already referring to what happened as the Scarlet Masquerade.

It fits. A neutral colored masquerade decorated in vivid shades of red—by a man who showed up wearing scarlet. If there was anything Katsuki stayed true to, it was his alias.

Izuku nervously jittered his leg with his hands folded in his lap. His stomach felt like he was on a boat rocking back and forth on a turbulent sea. He hoped it wasn't in Fate's plan that Katsuki was found out. He didn't want Katsuki to be hunted by the Yakuza—*but*.

Given what happened tonight, Izuku wondered who would really be hunting who.

He eyed his duffle bag in the corner.

Izuku turned to Aoyama with a forced smile.

"Where's Katsuma?" Izuku questioned with mild anxiety. "If you don't mind me asking."

"Oh, I dropped him off upstairs with the other kids," Aoyama explained. He leaned against the table with a sheepish smile. "A lower ranked Viper is taking care of them in the meantime until Chisaki tells us we can go."

"Ah. Okay," Izuku muttered. He gave a stiff smile. "Thank you."

Right as Aoyama seemed like he was about to ask something, the door to the room crept open. All their eyes turned. Walking in was Chisaki, his assistant and the four Yakuza men who had gone down to the database room. Chisaki's assistant was holding a large stack of papers in his hands.

"We found him," Chisaki announced.

Everyone's attention piqued while Izuku's heart dropped. He hoped they got the wrong guy.

Chisaki walked forward with his hands behind his back. He stopped in the middle of the room.

“It took a while. Turns out he’s clever,” Chisaki sincerely complimented. “He knocked out all the security cameras inside with a hack that looped the footage. There’s no proof of him inside the building *but*—based on descriptions from witnesses, we think we found him on CCTV footage near the venue.”

Izuku nervously wrung his hands.

“We got a clip of him with a hat and mask on,” Chisaki’s assistant said. The white haired man’s regal air encased him as he joined Chisaki in the middle of the room. “He was walking across the street to the back of the venue around the same time several guards were killed on the third floor. We were able to cross check our databases with the footage. We found a couple potential matches for an identity. But out of all the matches, only one had a solid motive to do something like this.”

“Bakugou Katsuki,” Chisaki spat.

Izuku’s stomach dropped straight to the ground.

He did his best not to give any reaction. Both Himiko and Tomura cut their eyes to him and then to each other. His brother and sister turned on their emotionless masks. Chisaki kept on speaking.

“He is the only child of Bakugou Mitsuki. I ordered for her to be killed five years ago for owing a debt.” Chisaki glowered. “Seems like both mother and son will always be thorns in my side up until the day they die.”

“Alrighty then,” Jin said eagerly. He gave a signature thumbs up with a bloodthirsty smile. “We have a name. Time to go bring him in—”

“—I’m not finished yet,” Chisaki interrupted. He held a single finger up and tilted his head. “There was a tiny, *tiny* detail in Bakugou Katsuki’s records that makes this all more… *interesting*. We didn’t even see it in the first pass. It was so small that I think most people would have overlooked it if they were not searching for it.”

“…Exactly what detail would this be?” Tomura questioned cautiously.

“Well,” Chisaki said and his eyes became dark. “Since he killed members of my family, I was searching for his family members. I wanted to kill them and make it even. A life for a life, if you will. But, he’s an orphan and has no known living relatives.”

Chisaki’s assistant then thumbed through the documents he was holding. He plucked a particular piece of paper from the stack. He handed it to Chisaki.

“However,” Chisaki drawled out. “It turns out he’s married—to Mamushi Izuku. Who is now legally listed as Bakugou Izuku.”

He turned the paper for everyone to see.

All hell broke loose.

Tomura's eyes went wild as he stood up fast enough to knock over his seat. Every Viper in the room began saying there must have been a mistake. Except for Himiko. She whirled on Izuku with disbelief etched into her face with her mouth dropped open. Ibara tried to be reasonable as always. She aided Tomura and Aoyama in saying that there was no way that document was real.

But Izuku could recognize the document from his seat. It was a photocopy of their marriage certificate plain as day.

He had forgotten marriages were public record.

Izuku's heart urged him to make a sprint for the door. He needed to flee, grab the kids and make a run for it. However, his logic told him there was no real point in putting up a struggle with this many Yakuza in the room.

Dreadful acceptance began to make itself home in Izuku.

Tomura stalked up to Chisaki and grabbed the piece of paper out of his hands.

"No," Tomura whispered. His eyes stretched as wide as the moon as he read the document. He violently shook his head and scowled. "This has to be a set up. I would have known if my little brother was *married*—"

"—Look at the date," Chisaki pointed out. "This was the week right after we made our deal. Then he disappeared without notice on an assignment. It's very clear this was done on purpose. For what reason? I'm not sure. But your brother likely conspired with that fucking lowlife to harm my family. It's *obvious*."

"Izuku, tell them that you're not married," Aoyama urged. He looked flabbergasted. "They must have gotten something wrong. It could be a mix up in the records."

But Izuku knew there was no use in denying it.

Chisaki was giving him a tyrannically, furious glare.

As the weight of being caught flooded into Izuku, he squeezed his hands together. His fingernails bit into his skin painfully. His heart ached as he anxiously wanted to get to Katsuma. But knew he couldn't. And just like that, everything came crumbling down on top of him in a single night.

The Yakuza seized Izuku immediately, folding him down over the table with excessive force. He clenched his jaw through the pain and he was manhandled towards the exit with his hands behind his back.

Izuku didn't resist.

"I want him locked up in one of the holding cells in the other rooms," Chisaki demanded loudly. He turned his heated glare on to Tomura's frigid one. "As repentance for what

happened tonight, you will execute five Vipers. A family member for a family member. Those are my terms."

Tomura curled his fist. "*What*?"

"What do you mean *what*?" Chisaki mocked. He tilted his head at Tomura. "Would you rather I take back my offer for your seat at the Tokyo Underground Council? Because trust me, that can be done as well, *Tomura*. I would prefer not to do that since I was sincerely looking forward to working with you. But, he's probably not even a virgin, is he?"

Chisaki turned his nose up at Izuku.

"And to think, I kissed his *filthy* mouth," Chisaki spat. "For such perfect beauty, he really is a goddamn snake. But you all are, aren't you? Especially you, Tomura. I will have to really reexamine the deal we made. You sold me on him under false pretenses."

"No. I didn't. I swear I didn't know," Tomura defended. He didn't look at Izuku as his anger rattled. "*None* of us knew about this."

"Luckily, I don't give a damn," Chisaki quipped. "The only thing I care about is you bringing me five cold bodies to my home before sunrise. And I want them to be *important* bodies, not simply anyone. Your makeshift family will feel the same pain as mine tonight. Then we can call it even."

Chisaki cut his glare towards Izuku. His greedy gaze raked him up and down.

In the back of his eyes was a flicker of sourness. It mirrored a spoiled child who hadn't gotten to play with the toy he had been promised. Izuku could tell Chisaki had never been denied anything. And for the first time in his life, Izuku had denied him a way. Led him on, even.

It was here Izuku knew what was next. Because if Chisaki couldn't have him, no one could.

Chisaki's eyes continued to burn into Izuku with a contorted selfishness.

"And Izuku will be one of those bodies," Chisaki hissed.

ɯɯɯ

Izuku was beginning to think that omen for winter coming early was true.

How horrific his luck had been in the last string of hours. Not only did he have Katsuki hunting him, now Chisaki was demanding his head. Everything was twisted about in an awful web of entanglement.

He tucked himself further in the corner of the holding cell.

He was still in the basement, several doors down from where everyone was. He could hear yelling down the hall from Chisaki and Tomura. Their voices were clashing like different

elemental titans in a battle. Tomura was no doubt trying to talk Chisaki off the ledge. But from the sounds of it, it wasn't working.

Izuku eyed the lock on the cell. He needed to get out of here somehow and get to the kids.

Soon, the yelling died out. Several people began to walk his way. He recognized a handful of the footsteps. Jin. Ibara. Himiko. Tomura. But others he didn't. His heart rate increased when he heard Tomura say, "Wait here for a moment."

The door slammed open, and Tomura flew in like a storm. He looked fit to kill Izuku with his bare hands.

"Stand the hell up," Tomura commanded. "You're going to tell me what the fuck is going on right now."

Izuku lifted himself with a light wobble. The exhaust in his bones was beginning to rear its head as he walked to the front of the cell.

"You got *married*? To that fucking lunatic?" Tomura seethed with words so sharp Izuku felt them cut into his skin. "What the hell were you *thinking*?!"

"It was an accident," Izuku admitted meekly. "We were blackout drunk."

"Then why did you not get a goddamn *divorce*?"

Izuku wished he had an answer for that. He truly didn't know.

That was the one detail that didn't align when Izuku recounted everything that occurred tonight. If Katsuki was so hellbent on killing him, why hadn't he filed the divorce papers? What was the point of remaining married if this was what he was going to do?

Something didn't quite seem right. And his intuition was gnawing at him because of it.

"I…I don't know," Izuku said honestly. "I sent him the divorce papers after everything, but he never signed them I suppose."

Tomura's eyes narrowed further. "You sent them to that estate in Biei?"

"Yes. I-I guess he really didn't want a divorce."

Tomura let out an angry huff and rolled his eyes.

"How could you fuck up this badly, Izuku?" Tomura nearly yelled. "This has got to be the biggest misstep you've *ever* made. Now other Vipers are going to pay the price for your mistake. Everything was set up perfectly."

"Perfectly?" Izuku parroted. Anger swelled in his chest. "How was any of this *perfect*?"

"It was all perfect until you went and married the violent *serial killer*."

“Maybe it was perfect for *you*.” Izuku glared at Tomura. Tears gathered at the bottom of his eyes from the jab at Katsuki. “I never wanted the arrangement with Chisaki. None of this would have happened if you had found something else—*anything* else—that Chisaki would have wanted. But no, you gave him *me* instead!”

Izuku’s voice cracked on the last word. He hated how tears slipped down his face.

“And Katsuki would have never done what he did if I had told him the truth like I originally wanted to,” Izuku said pointedly. “Now everything is a *mess* because of you. But at least you might still keep your seat at the table, *right*? Like always, you got everything *you* wanted,” Izuku concluded with distaste in his voice.

Tomura scoffed. He looked at Izuku like he was deeply naive.

“I didn’t get everything I wanted, Izuku,” Tomura whispered with a snarl. “I wanted to keep you *safe* and I wanted to *merge* us with the Yakuza.”

Izuku’s anger faltered from confusion.

He blinked rapidly to clear his bleary eyes.

“What do you mean merge with the Yakuza?” Izuku asked cautiously.

“All those years ago, when I said I can get power through Chisaki, I genuinely meant *through* him,” Tomura explained in a hush volume. “When we merge with the Yakuza, Vipers will skyrocket up the ladder in the Underground. And I would be able to dethrone that spoiled brat in less than five years as the head of The Tokyo Underground Council once I got on the inside of the Shie Hassaikai.”

There was that word that defined Tomura’s life: Power.

Power was all Tomura cared about. Izuku saw now, he was always a means to an end for Tomura’s struggle to power in a way. Izuku wondered where Tomura’s lust for power ended and his affection for him began. Or if they were even separated at all.

Maybe to Tomura, they were the same thing.

But the concept of merging the Vipers with the Shie Hassaikai was far-fetched. Not even Izuku really understood how Tomura thought he was going to pull that off.

“And how would we merge with them?” Izuku asked half heartedly.

“Think. Historically, how do powerful families usually merge together?”

Izuku went still. His skin dropped several temperatures as he shifted to look at Tomura sideways. Tomura’s eyes continued to sink into him. He waited with patience for the answer to come to Izuku. Steadily, only one thing came to mind.

Marriage.

Izuku's eyes began to creep wider and wider.

A light as bright as the sun shone down on all of Tomura's actions. The last few years flashed before Izuku's eyes from an entirely new angle.

He revisited how Tomura used to meet with One and Chisaki alone. Then he thought about how Tomura privately went out of his way to get close to Chisaki. He gained Chisaki's respect and trust under Nine's nose.

He recalled how Tomura stopped hitting him right after Chisaki laid eyes on him. Then Tomura went out of his way to fix his skin. He even made Izuku seem desirable to all of Hadeus. But more importantly, he made it known he controlled Izuku.

Selling his virginity specifically to Chisaki was a forceful way to bring them together. The seat at the table was simply a stepping stone to be seen as equals so that when Tomura proposed the merge, he would be taken seriously.

Izuku replayed the conversation he had with Chisaki on the dance floor. The strangeness made sense now. Tomura told Chisaki about his defect on purpose. He wanted to make sure Chisaki knew Izuku was capable of romantic feelings, unlike other Vipers.

Which opened the door for things such as dates. And ultimately, led to marriage if the cards were played right. It's why Chisaki went out of his way to host a giant ball. Even promised two weeks of romance. It was all done in order to try to *woo* Izuku.

Then finally, Izuku recalled what Tomura said to him right before he left for Okinawa. He thought it was strange, but he never fixated on it too much. Until now.

"Maybe if you're lucky he'll buy you again and it'll bud into some sort of ritual," Tomura had said. *"I would allow you to date, if it was Chisaki."*

"You…You never intended for me and Chisaki to be a one night thing," Izuku whispered, horrified. "Did you?"

Tomura's cold, calculating gaze grew frosty. He narrowed his eyes on Izuku and lowered his chin. The scar over his eye crinkled and the fangs on the tattooed vipers on his neck seemed deadlier.

"No," Tomura admitted. "I didn't."

Izuku's body hollowed out.

He shook his head slowly and backed away. He pressed himself against the wall to get the furthest away from Tomura as he could be.

"I practically gave you Chisaki on a silver platter tonight," Tomura angrily remarked. "Do you know how much I went out of my way to constantly talk you up to him? I made you sound like the most precious thing on this planet to possess."

Izuku shook his head. He tried to block out Tomura's words, but he kept going.

“Chisaki is *deeply* infatuated with the concept of you because of your beauty,” Tomura said. “You know this. It’s the never ending tango between beauty and power. The most powerful only liked to be coupled with the most beautiful. It makes sense to people like Chisaki for their future spouse to be an unobtainable beauty that only they could get.”

“N-No,” Izuku whispered. He shook his head more. “That’s going too far, Tomura!”

“It’s not too far, it was me looking *out* for you,” Tomura countered. “It would have been a win-win for everyone. Chisaki would have his trophy. You would have your romance. And I would have Yakuza level power. If you simply went along with what I set up, you would have gotten the fairy tale romance you’ve been craving all your life with the most powerful man in Japan.”

“You’re *insane*,” Izuku spat. His heart began erratically racing. “A marriage between us would have never happened because I would have never agreed to that!”

“You would have if you were never in love with that goddamn blond,” Tomura hissed. “I have always tried my best to accommodate you because of your defect. But I’m *done*. A marriage between you and Chisaki doesn’t have to have your consent because you missed the part where your opinion ultimately doesn’t matter.”

Tomura’s eyes darkened and the scowl on his face grew.

“If Chisaki still asked me permission to have you, I will gladly give it,” Tomura promised. “And if everything goes correctly with my help, it would lead to the final business deal between us: a marriage. Then we would *all* be family after that—and *family nepotism* is the easiest access to power. I learned that from the novel of yours I read so long ago.”

Izuku felt sick to his stomach.

This whole time, Tomura was setting him up to be a goddamn Yakuza bride.

What’s worse, Izuku feared that Tomura could *still* arrange for that to happen. Tomura and Chisaki were friends, in a twisted fashion. Tomura held a certain persuasion over Chisaki. It wouldn’t take too long for Tomura to convince Chisaki marrying Izuku would be the best way to *own* him.

But then Izuku remembered: he was already married.

And now, because of that, Chisaki wanted nothing to do with him.

Tomura truly calculated everything down to the last detail. All except for him and Katsuki being wildly *stupid*.

Slowly, Izuku began seeing the irony in all this.

Izuku laughed a bit, and Tomura grew confused. Izuku laughed some more as he continued to think about it all. His and Katsuki’s dumb, accidental marriage was a full on blockade to Tomura’s path to total power.

Tomura narrowed his eyes. “Do you really think you should be laughing right now?”

“I’m laughing because your merge won’t ever work,” Izuku said. He chuckled sadly, thinking about his husband. “Chisaki wants me dead. He said it himself. And besides, he’ll never touch me now that he thinks I’m not a virgin. That was my whole appeal to him, wasn’t it? And I doubt that he’ll be happy with marrying another viper. He thinks of them as merchandise.”

At that, Tomura cruelly scoffed.

“Oh, *Izuku*,” Tomura said his name in a low, guttural drawl. “I have *always* found a solution to clean up your messes. Haven’t I?”

Tomura backed away from the cell and Izuku’s laughter died off.

“Now. I’m going to go negotiate with Chisaki,” Tomura declared as he headed to the door. “I’ll come up with a solution out of this, and get my way. Like I always do.”

Then he stopped. He glared at Izuku from over his shoulder.

“And Izuku—” Tomura said. “I want you to know, you will be *severely* punished for all of this; For going to Okinawa. For getting married. For lying and running away with that psychopath and throwing away your virginity. I will make sure you feel the weight of your deception for the rest of your life.”

Tomura exited the room, leaving him alone with that looming threat.

The weight of all the night’s events hit his shoulders. Steadily, Izuku slid down to the ground in fear.

Because even with all this mess, Tomura was right. He *did* always find a way out of impossible situations. Tomura’s skill to slither out of any fiasco with his silver tongue and brute strength was unmatched. He was something to be feared because he kept all his promises.

Which left the warning of a brutal punishment hanging over Izuku’s head.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku looked up when the door finally opened after several, long hours.

In walked all that remained of The Viper Seven. Beside them were several lower ranked Vipers holding rifles.

Ibara was wearing an indifferent expression that matched Jin’s. Himiko was suppressing a smile, as if she was enjoying all of this. But Aoyama seemed slightly skittish. He was looking down at the ground while he hugged his arm.

Tomura stood in the middle of the room.

“Well,” Tomura said. He clicked his tongue. “I got to keep my seat on the Council and I settled with Chisaki who the five Vipers to die will be.”

Tomura paused and turned his spiteful eyes on Izuku.

“Congrats, Izuku,” Tomura said. “Chisaki agreed that you can keep your life. But only on two conditions. The first is that you fully cooperate with the Yakuza and help lead them to where Bakugou is so they can put him down. The second is that you will now be spending two full months with Chisaki. If you don’t do either of these, they will collect your head. But of course, I told them you would be *happy* to oblige.”

Tomura, once again, found a way to save Izuku’s life.

However, Izuku held off on his reaction.

The atmosphere in the room was more suffocating than thick smog. Izuku walked up the front of the cell and grabbed the bars. He wearily glanced around at all his brothers and sisters. When Aoyama couldn’t lift his head, everything seemed off. Izuku then glanced at Ibara and she averted her face away from him.

“Who is being executed?” Izuku asked quietly.

“It’ll be the children of the last cohort,” Tomura said. “Five lives in exchange for five lives.”

Gravity twisted and wrangled Izuku’s whole body. At the same instance, time stopped.

“W-What?” Izuku gasped. “No—”

Tremors more violent than a roaring tide overtook Izuku. Several memories of Katsuma happily running around flashed before him. Then all the joyful times burned at the edges, swallowing Katsuma up whole. The fire consumed Katsuma’s future and all that remained was blood.

“No,” Izuku choked. His eyes stretched wide and his grip on the bars tightened. He shook his head violently as he stared at Tomura bewildered. “N-No you *can’t*!” Izuku yelled. “They’re *kids*! *Why*?! Why would you choose them?!”

But all Tomura did was stare back at him blankly.

“Because Chisaki agrees killing the children would be a proper exchange,” Tomura said bluntly. “It’s sadistic enough that it satisfies him. We will have to start over entirely with raising a new cohort. But he wants that as a punishment for us.”

The ground under Izuku felt like it flat out slanted.

His world went lopsided in a horrible, queasy motion. He nearly fell, knees buckling as his body viscerally reacted.

“B-But they’re only children, Tomura,” Izuku begged. His grip on the bars tightened until it hurt. “They’re innocent in all of this. You can’t do this to them—”

“—I can and I will,” Tomura promised. There was no remorse in his eyes or voice. “The kids aren’t exactly old enough to be truly valuable to me anyways. It’ll be easier to raise a new cohort from scratch versus replacing an older viper who is needed on assignments. What’s a mere five years in the grand scheme of things?”

A mere five years.

Izuku stared at Tomura, horrified.

“No,” Izuku desperately whispered. His knuckles turned white from his grip. “N-No. Please. There has to be another solution.”

Izuku wildly turned his head to everyone else in the room for help.

“Aoyama!” He called. But his brother didn’t react. “Y-You’re not going to let this happen are you?”

Silence.

“Aoyama?”

Izuku’s voice cracked as he called for Aoyama once more. But he was only ignored. Izuku’s vision blurred, and the scorch of tears overtook him. He choked back a sob as he saw more happy memories with Katsuma burning in front of him.

He shook his head and whirled to the next person.

“Ibara—You can’t think this is the correct solution?” Izuku asked with a splinter down his vocal cords.

But she didn’t lift her gaze. She kept her arms folded and remained neutral by Tomura’s side.

Izuku outright sobbed now, unable to control it. Everyone stayed quiet as they let Izuku process the information. It was as if they knew this would be hard for him to accept. They waited out his emotional firestorm with patience.

“J-Jin,” Izuku called next. “Jin. Please. *Please*. You guys can’t be okay with this. Y-You can’t be.”

“It’s what Chisaki thinks is fair, Izuku,” Jin replied with a level of exhaustion. Like this was all too troublesome. He was the only one besides Tomura able to meet his eyes. But he didn’t have an ounce of compassion inside of them.

“We also can’t deny Chisaki what he wants,” Ibara finally spoke. She shook her head and kept her eyes down. “Besides, what Tomura said is right. We can always get another cohort. It’s the least impactful on us logistically. But, giving Chisaki the lives of five children will make him satisfied. It’s callous in the way Chisaki likes.”

The grasp Izuku had on the string of hope slipped.

It slipped down and down until he saw five, small graves aligned in a row. Katsuma. Eri. Kota. Hana. Tamashiro. He could see their headstones. This was the very thing he wanted to prevent and now he was locked in a cage.

Izuku turned to the last person there.

“Himiko.” He called her name like it was the final lifeboat setting sail from a wreckage. “Himiko. Please.”

She did not look nor say anything to him right away. She glanced at him once and then turned her head to the side.

Izuku stared in disbelief. How could they all be so complicit?

But he knew how. It was because they felt nothing. Absolutely *nothing*. This all simply boiled down to a five year waste of time for them. But to Izuku these were *stolen* children’s lives being tossed away. However, that’s how it always has been, hasn’t it? Lives thrown away so wastefully.

They would simply get more kids.

He could see it: Tomura would find another five victims. He would bend and break them; mold them to be new additions to their giant viper machine. No one would do anything. They would all stand by and watch as the viper consumed its own tail in an endless cycle of death. Every new addition truly was a new link in the chain to keep the viper fed.

Chunky, ugly teardrops fell from Izuku’s face.

Izuku glared at Tomura through the metal bars. Tomura stared at him right back, unfazed. Izuku seethed and his chest began to heave up and down. His core burned with rage as hot as a thousand coals. He hated the indifference in Tomura’s eyes.

Izuku banged on the cell bars, shaking them violently. “Let me out of here. Right *now*!”

“That won’t be happening,” Tomura replied sharply. He began to slowly slide on his leather gloves and flexed his hands. “I decided it’s best if you stay locked in here while we do what we need to do.”

“I’m sure you understand,” Ibara tried to comfort. “You’re a liability.”

“Let me out!” Izuku screamed at the top of his lungs. He banged on the bars more, rattling them furiously. “L-Let me see Katsuma! Please! Don’t do this!”

Izuku slipped into hysterics.

He began screaming and shaking the cage. All the memories from his childhood and Katsuma melted together into one. He not only failed Katsuma, but he also failed his younger self.

“Consider this your ultimate punishment, Izuku,” Tomura taunted heartlessly. “I hope losing Katsuma teaches you a valuable lesson. This is what happens when you deceive me. You should have thought twice before going behind my back.”

With those hateful words, Izuku pieced together that this was all Tomura’s idea.

The kids probably never even crossed Chisaki’s mind—but they definitely crossed *Tomura’s*. And he likely offered their lives as a terrible, twisted way to hurt Izuku. But because Chisaki was just as much of a sadist as his brother, he likely found it to be a grand idea and agreed.

“I won’t let you do this!” Izuku shrieked at a shrill volume. “I won’t! I’m not going to let any of you touch them!”

“Jin,” Tomura calmly called. He snapped his fingers and pointed to Izuku. “Handle him as we discussed. I’m going to go with Himiko to escort Chisaki home. He’s tired and wants to retire for the night and all his members would like to leave as well.”

“Got it,” Jin replied.

Izuku hyperventilated as Tomura began walking out the room.

Izuku’s eyes were wild as Tomura left. He watched one by one as Aoyama, Himiko, and Ibara left too. No one spared him a glance.

“Get back here!” Izuku screamed, spittle looped across the sides of his mouth. He banged and banged until he could feel the metal nearly give into him. “Tomura! *Tomura*!”

Then Izuku heard Jin move.

He whirled his head up to see Jin flipping a rifle. Jin took the blunt end of it and struck Izuku in the forehead in a single, hard blow from between the bars.

Izuku’s world went dark as he dropped to the ground.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku groaned as he slowly blinked open his eyes.

It was blurry. Everything was in double vision and out of focus. Izuku gasped as he turned over on the dingy floor. He lifted his head, and in the distance he saw double vision of a figure. The person turned around at the sound of his groan.

It was Jin, smiling. There were two of him looking down at Izuku with a malignant gleam in his eyes.

“Ah, good. You’re up,” Jin cackled. “Right on time. I was about to wake you.”

Izuku fought against the queasiness in his stomach. He lifted himself up on his wobbling arms and gradually the world around him came back into focus.

The double vision of Jin he was seeing vanished, snapping him into one figure. He was wearing his all black fighting gear now, and there was a gun on his waist holster. On his back were his two katanas, crossed like an X.

Hooked to his belt were keys in a large, rustic circle.

They dangled, and Izuku could piece together those were the keys to his cell.

Jin sauntered over with a whistle and squatted down to Izuku's level. He smiled languidly.

"Yakuza boogeymen are all gone," Jin said. "Tomura and Himiko are with Chisaki. But Tomura put me in charge of watching you. He wanted you to make sure you were awake so you could be able to hear them die from far away. Y'know. As part of your punishment."

The distant sound of giggling children reached Izuku's ears.

Every nerve in his body went on high alert. Izuku scrambled upright and adrenaline surged through his limbs. He grabbed the bars of the cell and stared wide at the door. He heard the sound of tiny feet marching.

"Jin, listen to me. Stop this before it's too late," Izuku begged. "Don't let Tomura go through with this."

"Sorry, Izuku," Jin said. "You brought this on yourself. You have a lot of explaining to do to the Yakuza after we put down the kids."

Izuku screwed his eyes shut.

"I'm sorry. Please, Jin. I'm really fucking *sorry*. I-I can explain all of it to Chisaki, but stop this. I'll do anything! Whatever he wants!" The sound of the kids was far away now. But they were still in close enough range that Izuku could hear them. "This is *sick*."

"Not sick enough if you ask me," Jin jabbed. He stood up and looked down at Izuku from over his nose. "This is Tomura's call anyways. He knew your defect would make you grieve for the kids, so. This is what you get for fucking up."

Jin walked away to go sit at the table across the way. His posture was as if this was just any other day. He kicked his feet up and pulled out his phone. He started playing a game on his phone, ignoring everything.

Izuku began crying angrily.

He heard the sound of children playing in the back and covered his ears. He dropped to his knees in the cell. He pressed his palms flat against his head. But he couldn't drown out the sounds of their voices. Izuku shook his head with fever. He did this over and over until he made himself dizzy.

Then a dark shadow stepped into view from out of the corner of his eye.

He crept his gaze to the side to see the ghost of Hiryu staring at him.

The bullet hole in the skull was wider now, and the eyes were fully inky like a demon. The ink ran over, spilling down his face like tears. In the reflection of Obsidian eyes, Izuku saw himself. But what was most unnerving was how close the ghost was—a mere few inches from his face.

“No,” Izuku whispered. He squeezed his eyes shut. “Not now. You’re not real. Go away.”

Jin turned his head and raised an eyebrow at the whisper. He paused for a moment then he went back to playing his phone game.

Izuku opened his eyes. He hoped there would be nothing, but there it was: the face of his dead brother.

The shadow was startling close, unlike ever before.

“Aish, this again?” Hiryu’s ghost mumbled. “That’s what you said last time you were locked in a cage with me. Have you really not figured out what I am yet?”

“You’re nothing but the side of me that feels guilty for Hiryu’s death,” Izuku whispered angrily.

This time, Jin put his phone down. He said, “Oi. Quit muttering to yourself, it’s creeping me out.”

Izuku ignored him, too compelled by the vision in front of him.

At the lack of response Jin grumbled under his breath. He waved his hand dismissively and said some obscenity about Izuku. He went back to paying attention to his phone and lit himself a cigarette with the lighter that was on his key chain.

“I’m far more than a guilty conscience,” The phantom said.

It tapped its own temple several times and slowly the appearance of Hiryu melted. It disintegrated down to reveal a shadow mirror image of Izuku. Its hands were covered in dried blood up to its forearms. In his eyes was a dark fire and its mouth was curled fiercely into a depraved leer.

“I’m your instinct to *survive*,” it whispered hauntingly.

Its ghost-like voice stretched through Izuku’s skull, starting on one side and ending on the other. It oscillated steadily from one ear to another as it spoke.

“I’m the desperate part of you that will do whatever it takes to live,” it whispered. “No matter the taboo consequences. I was born that day you killed Sen, we had met on the bus ride home. But I truly started to show my face when you killed *Hiryu*. Someone who loved you but you still *killed* him in order to save your own skin.”

The shadow glowered and tilted its head.

“You keep repressing me with useless guilt,” it chastised. “Stop it. You should never apologize for surviving. From here on out, we need to be in harmony from now on if you want to live.” It jutted its chin to Jin across the room. “Look at him.”

Izuku did.

He turned his teary gaze to his brother. Jin was laughing at his phone while the sound of the kids talking were in the background. He inhaled a puff from his cigarette and tutted the ashes on the table.

“What an arrogant, soulless creature.” The shadow said what Izuku was thinking. “What type of person would kill a kid? I’ll tell you, someone who isn’t a person. But a snake would do it. And they’re all terrible vile *snakes*.”

Izuku’s sadness stopped. His sorrow calcified down to its bare bones and hardened into fury. Then the feeling of a hook inside of his gut caught. It pulled and pulled until his rage came close to the surface.

“Ah. There’s that instinct,” the shadow said. It smirked at him. “I can finally feel you pulling from me again. That dire need inside of you to survive is so potent. But somehow, it’s bigger than before. Is it because you’re not surviving only for yourself now?”

Izuku thought of Katsuma. The rage in his gut pulled viciously.

“Tell me. Do you want to save them?” The shadow asked. “Do you want them to *survive*?”

“Yes,” Izuku whispered desperately. “I do.”

“Then *accept* me,” the shadow hissed. It leaned in with a menacing scowl an inch away from Izuku’s face. “Accept the violence you have in your heart when it comes to survival. Accept you are a cold blooded killer and if you do, I can get you out of here.”

The shadow held out a hand dripped in black ink.

With shaking fingers, Izuku grasped that part of his soul in a tight hold.

The shadow simpered and gave Izuku its ferocity.

It was like being electrocuted. Izuku was shocked wide awake, for once seeing himself without shame. The surge of all his instincts combusted into pure adrenaline. Every sense was heightened. His anxiety morphed into raw energy and his lungs expanded with a breath of new air.

For the first time, Izuku accepted himself.

The violence inside of him opened like floodgates. It poured inside of his body, overpowering his viper in its viscous, dark green liquid. The viper struggled and tried to slither out. But that shadow inside of him grabbed it by the neck. It pulled down the viper under the surface and drowned it alive.

His vertebrae stacked on top of each other, straightening out.

Izuku rolled his shoulders. He slowly stood up with his head lulled down. With steady hands, he took off his necktie and dropped it to the ground. He dragged his feet over to the front of the cell with his bangs covering his eyes.

Izuku leaned in and grabbed a hold of the bars.

Jin looked up again. He waited for Izuku to move, but instead Izuku kept his head down, hiding his eyes under his bangs. Jin scoffed and finally locked his phone. He put it face down on the table with a bang.

He walked over to the cell.

“Can you stop crying already? It’s getting annoying,” Jin jeered. He cringed at the tears running down Izuku’s cheeks. “Ugh. Himiko was right about you. You aren’t a real viper at all.”

“…You’re right, I’m not,” Izuku whispered quietly.

He snapped open his eyes and lifted his head. His pupils were constricted down into terrifying, tiny dots. It left nothing but a sea of viridian venom.

“I’m a viper killer,” Izuku snarled.

Izuku shot his hand out and an entire lifetime of Tomura’s lethal training snapped into place.

He grabbed Jin’s arm and pulled it through the bars. Jin stumbled, taken off guard. With unnerving speed, Izuku snapped back Jin’s arm on a metal bar. Jin screamed in agony as his arm was broken clean in two. Blistering pain radiated through him.

Quickly, Jin gritted his teeth as he tried to yank back his limb. But Izuku’s vicious hold was too tight.

Izuku’s nostrils flared as he sunk his claws deep into Jin’s flesh. He drew blood and showed teeth. Izuku’s poisonous gaze became feral as he looked down. He homed in on the keys rattling from Jin’s side.

Jin reached for his gun, but Izuku was quicker.

Izuku took a hold of Jin’s mangled arm and twisted it around. They both screamed out as Izuku flipped Jin’s whole body and slammed him down to the ground. The satisfying crunch of bone breaking amplified Izuku’s ambition.

Jin swiftly recovered, however.

He seized the gun at his waist. He aimed it at Izuku and pulled the trigger.

Izuku barely had enough time to dodge as the bullet grazed him. He ducked millimeters below Jin’s line of fire. The searing graze of the bullet hit his ear. He hardly felt it, though.

The rage inside of him consumed the pain like it was merely fuel.

Izuku grabbed Jin's other wrist and forced the gun to fire towards the ceiling. He then yanked the other arm into the holding cell with him. Jin groaned as his face hit the hard surface. Izuku yanked the limb again and again, making sure to hurt Jin. Then he gave the other arm the same treatment.

He snapped the arm against a metal bar until it broke clean.

Jin's body twitched violently. He began screaming for back up when the gun dropped out of his hands. It landed right into the cage. Jin tried to struggle away from Izuku. But Izuku held a steel hold on his broken arm. He pressed his fingers into the fragmented bones, wanting to make it hurt.

He *wanted* Jin to feel the agony he felt.

Izuku snatched the gun up before Jin could make a move for it.

Then, without hesitation, he pulled the trigger.

The loud gunshot was followed by deafening silence. The bullet ended his brother's life and Izuku felt close to nothing. The red liquid poured out of Jin's head and began to pool around him.

Suddenly, the sound of rushing footsteps came. Izuku's head snapped up when the door opened and in flew three lower ranked Vipers. He saw them as the filthy snakes they were and scowled.

They immediately fired their guns at him. Izuku ducked the bullets as fast as he could. Two grazed him but he pushed through the pain the way Tomura trained him to: make himself feel nothing.

He countered with three precise bullets and landed them in the other viper's kneecaps. They crumbled, like a pile of bricks. Izuku fired off three more right between their eyes.

Their bodies hit the floor with a satisfying thud.

Izuku worked with haste. He put the gun in his pant's waistline and ran over to Jin's corpse. He pulled at the body until it flipped over. There were the keys to the cell. Izuku grappled for them and hastily unlocked the door.

Izuku stared coldly down at Jin and eyed the Katanas. He took one in his hand, unsheathed it, and tested the weight.

His gaze grew more serious when he heard more people coming this way. There must have been Vipers in the hallways making rounds. Racing against time, Izuku sprinted out of the room. He followed the bouncing echo of children and took off towards it.

"Please don't be too late," Izuku whispered to himself as he picked up speed.

He rounded the corner and awaiting him was an attempt to inject him with a syringe. Izuku hissed and ducked back and the needle nicked him lightly. He recognized it as a paralyzer.

He was forced backwards and bum rushed by six more lower ranked Vipers.

The six of them tried to overpower him with skilled knife attacks. They were fast. Succinct and precise. But Izuku deflected with fluidity only someone who was in The Viper Seven possessed. He was top ranked for a reason, and he could see them realize it as soon as they began losing the struggle.

Izuku drew the katana and began to go on the offense. The clashing of metal bounced off the walls as Izuku cut into them. He slashed away at them, and blocked with the weapon in a way only Tomura knew how.

He proved in that savage moment that Tomura's efforts to shape him into a merciless killer were not in vain. They blossomed into the most brutal, protective killer instinct.

Izuku didn't blink as he rammed the katana through one of the Vipers' stomachs. His sibling choked up blood with wide eyes. Izuku then removed his blade, spun, and gutted another Viper behind him in the same motion.

Blood sprayed across his face and he *reveled* in it.

More Vipers came. Countless, flew from around the corners from their guard duty to stop him. But Izuku was unfazed seeing them.

Through his eyes, all he saw were complicit links in an endless chain of death. They were part of that spiraling viper that endlessly ate its tail. And if he didn't chop off the head, more innocent lives would be lost. So, one by one Izuku mercilessly hacked them down.

With every soul he reaped he broke the chain further and further.

One. Two. Six. Ten. Fourteen. Twenty. He killed them all with no regrets.

He slashed the throat of one Viper and cut off the arm of another, bleeding them out. When he was the last man standing, Izuku stopped to catch his breath. The hallway was packed with butchered, dead bodies of all his siblings.

For a fleeting moment, he wondered if Tomura would be proud of him. He was finally the killing machine Tomura always wanted him to be.

He gazed around with sub zero eyes, satisfied with his cull.

Izuku's rage dove further into oblivion as he stepped over the heap of limbs. His venomous gaze became more harrowing at the sound of one set of footsteps approaching.

He knew those footsteps. Light, like someone was gliding across the air.

Around the corner came Ibara.

She gazed around, shocked at what she saw. Then she looked up to meet Izuku's eyes. A flicker of emotions resurfaced in Izuku. But then he looked down at her hand. She was armed with her thorned whip.

She began giving him a pitiful stare like he was a lost soul. It was the exact stare she gave people before she killed them.

Izuku's gaze grew more intense.

Using training Tomura taught him, Izuku forced down the side of him that felt something for her. It worked. She was nothing more than an obstacle, another complicit link in the chain, and Izuku needed her gone.

"Move out of the way, Ibara," Izuku demanded.

"You know I can't do that, Izuku," Ibara replied softly. She unraveled her whip and it hit the ground with its heaviness. "Please. Stop and think. This is what the kids are destined for. Maybe in the next life they can find proper peace. But they won't have it in this one."

"I said move," Izuku threatened. He gripped the sword with both hands and took an attack stance. "I won't ask again."

"Your defect really has blinded you from logic," Ibara muttered sadly. She cracked her knuckles. "I'll be sure to pray for you after I put you into confinement. Tomura made it clear that you're not allowed to leave under any circumstance until Chisaki comes back for you tomorrow, so I won't."

She moved her fingers in the sign of the cross and struck.

Ibara's whip sliced through the air in a dangerous blur. It immediately came for him with its long reach. Izuku ran out of the way almost too late. The whip cracked next to his ear and he backflipped backwards to a safer distance.

Izuku knew to take the defensive. Unlike the Vipers he just culled, Ibara was far more skilled.

She proved herself immediately by lethally cutting her whip through the air again. And this time striking him. Blistering pain rippled through Izuku's arm from the thorns shredding his flesh.

Izuku hissed as he retreated backwards. But she kept going, aiming to cripple him. She landed several, horrible blows and he was covered in his own blood quickly.

He acrobatically dodged backwards and sideways, trying to calculate his next move.

She whirled as gracefully as a ribbon dancer and struck as deadly as a cobra. Strike after strike rained down like a storm. Then she was able to wrap the whip around Izuku's leg. She pulled with all her strength and Izuku flew. He was dragged through the blood on the ground towards her.

He saw in her hand a syringe of paralyzer. She was going to knock him out.

He dove further into his instinct to survive and struggled against the whip. Urgently, Izuku swung the sword and cut the whip where it was around his legs. He freed himself and scrambled up right. He hastily pulled out the severed section of whip that was sticking to his leg.

The thorns ripped through his flesh and Izuku ignored the pain.

He decided to go on the offensive. He sprinted close to Ibara while dodging some of her strikes. Those he didn't dodge, he ate with sheer will. When he finally was close range he steeled his nerve endings. She cracked her weapon again, and this time Izuku held up the sword.

The whip wrapped tightly around the katana like a snake and Izuku leveraged it to his advantage.

He used both hands to hold the sword from either end, allowing the blade to slice him. He yanked with all his strength.

She was pulled forward, and Izuku saw the opening to break another link.

He wrapped the whip tight around the blade with a twirl of his body. Then he whirled around her with his quickness. Ibara tried to move, but Izuku always had been the fastest of The Viper Seven. The whip followed Izuku's path and wrapped around Ibara's neck.

When it looped securely, Izuku gripped the length of the whip raw. He let the thorns sink into him as he absorbed the pain.

He pulled.

He squeezed his eyes shut as Ibara gasped in agony. The metal thorns from the whip sunk into her neck. Her eyes popped wide. She dropped the whip and fell to her knees. She grappled at her neck, trying to free herself. But she couldn't without being stabbed.

An onslaught of unwanted emotions hit Izuku. And he so desperately wanted to push them away. But instead, this time, he accepted them.

Blood trickled out of his sister's eyes as she looked up at him, gasping for air.

"I never was the defected one," Izuku whispered with tears in his eyes. "You all were."

Izuku gave a final, harsh pull. He felt a snap in the cervical spine.

Ibara's eyes rolled back as blood trickled down her neck. Her body dropped to the ground and Izuku's tears fell with her. His hands began to tremble as he saw the life slowly twitch out of her. He wished it didn't have to be like this, but it was. If she lived then she would enable Tomura in getting another cohort. And Izuku could no longer let this cycle continue.

The sound of Katsuma from down the hall returned Izuku's focus. He picked up the severed whip.

With the katana in one hand and the whip in the other, Izuku ran down the long hallway. He stayed on high alert. He expected more Vipers to come, but it seems as if he successfully cleared them all out for the time being.

When he reached the door with the kids, he kicked it open.

In the room was Aoyama and all the children.

Aoyama turned and his eyes stretched wide at the sight of Izuku. Izuku was now stained in blood from head to toe, his lace blouse entirely ruined.

Izuku glanced at the scene in front of him. With every detail, his heart broke more and more.

All the kids were sitting at the table. Their hands and feet were tied with rope. Worse, they had on noise canceling headphones. But they were laughing as if it was some sort of game.

In front of them was Aoyama, with a syringe in hand drawing from a bottle. The liquid was bright pink, bubbly and on its label was a snake symbol.

Izuku looked at the bottle and knew what it was.

It was The Viper Academy's biggest secret: Mamushi snake venom. It was the only poison they were not immune to. This was done on purpose in case a Viper needed to be put down quietly. It was a fail safe built into the system that only specific people knew about.

It's what Izuku was planning to use on Hiryu originally that night in Vienna.

Izuku looked at Aoyama sadly, unable to hide his disappointment in him.

All the kids were glancing between them, talking and calling their names. They now were confused. This game didn't seem so fun anymore and the sight of Izuku crying was upsetting Katsuma. But neither Aoyama and Izuku paid attention as they kept their eyes locked on the other.

"Aoyama," Izuku warned slowly. His tears flowed harder. "Put it down."

But Aoyama didn't. He glanced to the side and Izuku did too.

Sitting on the wall was a red button labeled 'emergency basement lock down'.

Izuku saw Aoyama inch towards it. Izuku held up the katana and stepped towards Aoyama as a warning.

"Izuku, don't be stupid," Aoyama begged. "C'mon. We both know this is what has to be done."

"*Why*?" Izuku asked. He took a step forward and Aoyama took a step back. "Why does it have to be done?"

"Because it's what Tomura said has to be done. And we can't disobey him or Chisaki."

"So you would kill the kids to appease them? Don't you feel bad for trying to take the life of a *child*?!"

"Of course I do, Izuku!" Aoyama screamed. He shook and his hands trembled as he held the syringe of venom in his hand. "Of *course* I feel bad! I loved them the same as you, but I am not willing to let your mistakes be the things that pull this family apart for good! The kids are going to be given as blood repentance so we can keep being a *family*. There will always be more kids!"

Izuku's heart broke clean in two.

This was a test. A test to see if Izuku should spare him, and Aoyama was failing.

"It doesn't have to be like this." Izuku tried once more. "Let me save them—*help* me save them."

Izuku put the katana down. He stretched out his hand to Aoyama, like he did so many years during The Cull.

But just like so many years ago, Aoyama stared at him like he had gone crazy for showing altruism.

"I'm sorry, Izuku." Aoyama backed away, not accepting the hand. "I'm not willing to bleed for you. I already told you that."

Izuku studied his favorite brother like all the colors drained from the world.

Aoyama stared at him right back with a reciprocated, disappointed expression.

His once vivid love for Aoyama shriveled down into nothing. Aoyama made it clear, he was going to kill the kids. Which meant he was as defective as all the other snakes Izuku needed to cull.

This, Izuku did not want.

But he needed to break one more link in the chain.

Aoyama made a run to press the emergency button. Izuku swung the whip and it wrapped around Aoyama's wrist right before he could press it. Aoyama yelled as the thorns sunk into his skin, piercing his flesh. Izuku yanked back the whip, pulling Aoyama closer to him. He picked up the Katana in the same motion. With no hesitation, Izuku swung the blade.

It cut clean through Aoyama's jugular vein and carotid artery.

Izuku dropped the whip and stepped back. He watched sadly as Aoyama scrambled to hold his neck. He pushed against the deep wound. But it was useless. Blood poured out from him and so did his life. He looked up at Izuku for help. But Izuku did nothing.

“I’m sorry I couldn’t save you in the end,” Izuku whispered sincerely.

Aoyama crumbled to the floor. He curled up. Blood soaked through his hair and painted his wrist red.

Izuku turned to the kids in the room.

An ache of guilt and overwhelming sadness stabbed through him.

He didn’t want to have to do that in front of them. But there was no other option. Maybe in the future, this would be a distant repressed memory. Like a foggy day dream they can only half remember unsure if it was a dream or not.

They all seemed particularly unfazed. All except Katsuma. Katsuma was looking at Aoyama’s twitching body confused with tears streaming down his face.

Izuku’s heart hurt more than he could express at that moment. But there was no leeway to focus on his emotions. It was only a matter of time before another Viper came from upstairs and noticed all the bodies.

He took the katana and cut each child free of their restraints.

They all looked at him, happy to see him. Izuku’s heart squeezed at their big eyes and smiles. He took off the headphones one by one. Immediately, Katsuma held his arms out for him to be comforted. Izuku squatted low to their height and hugged Katsuma tightly to him. He buried his hand in his hair to make sure he was real and safe.

He turned to the other kids, smiling past his tears.

“Who wants to go on a field trip?” Izuku asked.

ᔓᔓᔓ

There wasn’t much time, he knew that. Every second that passed inched all six of them closer to Tomura. Izuku held Katsuma in one arm as the tiny boy clung to his neck. In his other hand were Eri’s small fingers.

He told all the children to hold hands in an assembly line. He said they would play a game of ‘keep up with Izuku’.

As in, keep up with him as he ran frantically through the hallways.

He grabbed the single duffle bag that he packed before the masquerade. He flung it over his body with haste, and strung it tight to his form. On his way out, Izuku raided the bodies of the Viper’s he had killed for any supplies. He took as much ammo, money and guns as he could.

Then finally he patted down Jin's body. He searched for the one thing he knew Jin always kept on him: a key to his favorite sport's car. Izuku found it, and it shined with the promise of freedom.

Izuku stuffed the keyring in his pocket. He hastily headed towards the elevators.

When they finally made it up to the garage level, Izuku kept up a light jog. He ran past all the fancy cars and motorcycles. He repeatedly pressed the lock button on the keys until he heard beeping coming from one direction.

He turned on his heels and gestured for the kids to follow him.

They all ran to the car, full speed. When they got to it, Izuku knew which one it was. The car was a candy pink Ferrari Purosangue. Exactly Jin's tastes. Aligned next to it were more expensive, colorful cars that now will probably never be driven again.

Izuku popped open the trunk and flung in the bag, gun, money, and ammo. He rapidly took out the black folder he had stolen from Katsuki and his tiny notebook where he wrote all the kids' info.

He pulled out his phone next. With all his strength, Izuku smashed his phone on the ground. Next, he did the same thing to his laptop. He shattered the devices to tiny pieces, not chancing being tracked. He shut the trunk.

He loaded all the kids in the back seat and tightly buckled them in the best he could.

They all clapped and made jokes between themselves. He was overjoyed they were all convinced they were winning some pretend game. Everyone but Katsuma seemed fooled. When Izuku felt like they were strapped in safely enough for now, he closed the door. Izuku looked around frantically, keeping his eyes peeled.

Off to his side he saw a shelf.

He studied it. Then he saw a giant, red tub of gasoline sitting there.

A dangerous idea spun across his thoughts. He quickly walked up to the tub of gasoline. It was full. Izuku solidified his idea and threw the cap off. He began pouring out the gasoline onto the floor. His eyes burned from both the fumes and heartbreak. But he pushed through it. He dosed all of Jin's sports cars in the liquid.

Izuku then hastily headed towards the drivers side and strapped in. He splayed out the black folder on the passenger seat. All the details regarding Nana spilled out.

He looked at her picture, hopeful that she could bring the kids home.

Izuku turned on the car with his sweaty hands. He put it in gear.

His heart rate skyrocketed as he sped out of the garage. He put one hand on the wheel. The other was out the window, holding the jug of gasoline by the handle. Izuku made sure to trickle a trail of gasoline along the way.

When they breached outside, the winter winds poured into the car from the window.

Izuku looked back, and every memory lit up before his eyes. Misery. Agony. Everything blended together in a fury of over two decades of torture. All he wanted was to sear it out of his memory.

Bitter, green eyes gazed up. He glared at the penthouse.

With all his spite, Izuku tossed the empty jug of gasoline down to the ground.

He took the lighter off Jin's car keys.

He ignited the flame, and it danced in front of his eyes.

Izuku's resolve deepened and he flung the lighter down on the pile of gasoline.

It lit up. A beautiful, roaring line of fire began to eat its way towards the skyscraper. It followed the trail Izuku laid and soon, smoke began to form.

As everything caught fire, Izuku sped off. He hit the gas as hard as he could and didn't dare look back. If he did at that moment, he feared how much his heart would break.

The wind swept through all their hair as Izuku disappeared into the night. He sped all the way to the highway and only glanced in his rear view mirror once. There, he could see fire swelling. The smoke danced hand in hand with embers and reached towards the night sky.

Izuku gripped the wheel tightly when his heart became heavy. He reached down into his sock and ripped off the bracelet he had wrapped around his ankle.

He glanced down at the locket that held his tracker. His heart skipped a beat.

Then, he threw it out the window.

Izuku knew he had to hurry all the way to Nana. He couldn't make too many stops and he needed to lay low enough so that no one found him. There were, without a doubt, multiple people desperate to get him in their grasps. Chisaki. Tomura. And whoever else survived his chaos.

But there was only one person he worried about actually catching him—and it wasn't Tomura.

Scarlet eyes burned through all his thoughts.

Izuku knew Katsuki would keep his promise to always find him.

Again and again and again.

Chapter End Notes

locks doors and hides Thank you so much for reading! 💚🧡 Lemme know you're thoughts below—

Chapter 29: Sforzando

Chapter Summary

> Sforzando — (musical direction) to play a note with sudden, strong emphasis.
>
> Izuku and Katsuki have a contest of strength and speed. Which will be the victor in the end?

Chapter Notes

> Helloooo!! Welcome back :))
>
> First, I just want to say a huge thank you to the positive response at the last chapter! 🥹💕 I'm beyond happy everyone enjoyed the craziness. I'm still getting around to responding to everyone's comment from ch 28!! I'm so overjoyed you all liked it. I really loved writing the previous chapter and I also enjoyed writing this one :') this whole new leg of the fic I've been waiting for write for years. I hope you all enjoy what I have in store ^^ it's been such a long road LOL we officially hit 500k words <3
>
> Thank you all for sticking with this fic and always being so kind. I'm really appreciative of everyone who reads this story and comes along with me for these unhinged plots. I am rambling now so I will stop but truly thank you guys :')
>
> Without further wait, I hope you enjoy this chapter!
>
> **Warnings: Graphic Depictions of Violence and Angst**

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 29 — Sforzando

.

.

.

Izuku had been driving non-stop for hours.

During his exertion, the sky above him shape-shifted from a dark blue to a light lavender. It was a signal that the sun was coming up. The bloody trail of destruction he and Katsuki left behind them was likely coming to full light by now.

Everyone in Hadeus was probably talking about them. Or hunting them. Or more feasibly, doing both. It was going to be mayhem from here on out until the Yakuza got their hands on them.

But somehow, despite the looming dark cloud, Izuku only felt strangely calm.

He stared at the steadily rising sun in front of him.

The warmth that radiated through the windows felt like the hug he so desperately needed. And in a way, this sunrise was the light at the end of the long, dark tunnel he had been stuck in all his life.

He glanced in the backseat. All the kids were sound asleep, lost to their dreams. Each was leaning their heads on one another in uncomfortable upright positions. Eri was snoring the loudest, and Kota had his hand cupping Katsuma's cheek.

Izuku smiled sadly at them.

Even if this action cost him his life, he would be happy for it.

ᔓᔓᔓ

By the time they made it to the next major city, Izuku's eyes were beginning to burn.

He ran a shaky hand through his matted hair. The blood that had gathered on him from the Viper massacre was fully dried now. Bits of his siblings' blood were coming off like snowflakes from all over his body. It should have been off putting, but Izuku found it to feel freeing.

Before they got too thick in the crowds, Izuku pulled over on the side of the road for a breather.

The back of his eyes were beginning to hurt, signaling he had a migraine coming on. No doubt from all the emotions that he was repressing inside his chest. But he kept them on ice, not wanting to unthaw and face what he was feeling before they made it to safety.

Izuku glanced over at the black folder that was in the passenger seat. He pulled the item onto his lap with a shaky exhale and opened it.

The folder was chock-full of Katsuki's notes. There were dozens, no *hundreds*, of printed out papers. Every paper was some sort of clue or information that tied to Nana. Articles. Social media posts. Even some police reports were in here.

On the bottom of the stack was an extremely detailed map of Japan. It was large and needed to be folded several times over just to fit into the black folder. Out of everything, the map was

the most scribbled on item. There were highlights, arrows, and erratic question marks next to circled towns in different colors.

From what it seemed like, it was difficult to figure out where Nana exactly was. This was probably done on purpose to keep her operations away from the wrong type of people. But luckily for Izuku, Katsuki nearly cracked the code already.

His cunning, intelligent husband uncovered that Nana's previous alias was Float. Her new one however, was still a mystery. But it was a mystery that laid within all this information Katsuki had gathered.

Written at the top were two words of the alias that Katsuki already decoded: One. All.

Izuku kicked up his feet and uncapped a pen with his teeth. He got to work. He began scribbling, scanning, and shuffling through all the info.

As he did this, he could feel a bit of Katsuki with him. Through these notes, Izuku felt how much of a perfectionist Katsuki truly was. He was extremely thorough and barely left any stone unturned. If there was anyone on this planet who could win a prize for being meticulous, it would be Katsuki.

Going through the information took a longer time than Izuku thought. When he felt even halfway through it, the sun was all the way up in the sky. He heard one of the kids rouse in the back. Izuku nervously looked out of his window, weary that some Viper would appear and try to drag them back to Tokyo.

But when all the kids were awake again, it clicked.

Izuku wrote the last word in ink next to where Katsuki had written the other two.

He stared at the page in disbelief.

One For All.

That was Nana's new alias.

A smile as warm as the morning sun shined across Izuku's bloodied face. He chuckled lightly, overjoyed. He and Katsuki cracked the code together in a roundabout way. They did always make a great team when they weren't at odds against each other.

Izuku examined the marked-up map. It was clear Nana didn't stay in the same city too long. But, from what Izuku pieced together, she moved with a pattern. There were seven different cities she frequented with an infrequent pace. But it was always the same ones in the same order. Sapporo. Aomori. Niigata. Kyoto. Fukuoka. Osaka and lastly, Okinawa.

And if Izuku was right, Osaka was her next stop.

He glanced up at the sign that read 'Welcome to Nagano!' And caught a second wind of energy.

He put it in gear once more and got back on the road.

ᔓᔓᔓ

They needed to make a handful of quick, discreet pit stops.

Turns out, traveling with half a dozen five-year-olds was more chaotic than he thought it was going to be. Everyone always needed to pee, and they were all a bit antsy from sitting in the car for so long. Izuku ended up making everyone switch seats because Kota kept biting Hana and Tamashiro kept sticking his finger up Katsuma's nose.

On top of this chaos, the winter winds were making everyone cold. Unfortunately, they couldn't exactly stop for supplies given Izuku's alarming appearance. So instead Izuku settled for dressing them in the clothes he had packed originally for Chisaki's place.

He pulled a thin, blue hoodie over his own body and put on sunglasses to cover his eyes. As for the kids, he packed exactly ten sweaters that he could work with. He layered each child in two sweaters, bundling them up the best he could.

Izuku couldn't help but giggle. They looked so cute and goofy in the oversized material.

They began asking him questions about where they were going. They even asked when they would be able to go back to training. Izuku nearly winced at that one. It was hard to skirt around the truth. But he simply said they were going to go stay with other family members.

When they finally made it to beautiful Osaka, it was twilight outside.

This type of dusk orange sky was Katsuma's favorite color. The whole car ride in, Katsuma could barely contain his excitement. He kept gasping and pointing at the way the orange color was spilling all over. It painted the grass, trees, and the glass buildings.

Then it slowly all faded away. The navy-blue night sky waltzed in and Izuku began looking for a place to park the car.

He wanted to park a bit away from where Nana was. His intuition was telling him it may be time to ditch the vehicle. Who knew how long it would be before Tomura or someone realized which car exactly was missing from the garage after sifting through the fire.

Izuku drove around a bit, then stopped when he saw the perfect spot.

It was a seven-story parking garage. It was secluded enough that it didn't draw attention and also fairly well hidden. No one would likely walk in it and be searching for a bright fuchsia sports' car.

Izuku drove up to the third floor, directly in the middle. He parked the car in the corner behind a pillar.

As they got out of the car, Izuku gathered the black folder and his notebook in his hands. He packed them up in his duffle bag and secured the bag to his body. For extra measure, Izuku

pulled up the hood of his hoodie over his hair. He tucked any loose strands in wisely, so no peak of green was visible. He drew the draw strings tight and put on a pair of sunglasses over his eyes.

He put each of them in face masks to cover their faces the best they could. When he felt like they wouldn't be well spotted on camera, he got a move on.

They walked away from the car and began their journey into Osaka under the moonlight.

As they walked, Izuku clutched the map in his unsteady hands.

He led them to the street where he pinpointed Nana's Osaka operation must've been at. When he got there, it turned out it was not a street, but an alley. It was crooked and narrow but held a handful of people. He held on tighter to the children and told them all to walk in front of him holding hands.

As they walked through the alley, several people glanced at him oddly. The bit of blood on his face was likely making people gawk. But Izuku kept it moving, not daring to meet anyone's eyes.

He read every sign, looking for something that hinted to where Nana was. But when he reached the end of the alley, he became confused. He saw nothing. Izuku frowned and whirled around. He walked the length of the alley again.

Izuku walked up and down the narrow alley several times. Each time with increasing panic.

He thought he was going to go crazy. He looked up at the signs once more and clutched the map in his hand. He whirled around and the kids did too, spinning with him like it was a fun game. Izuku clenched his teeth as he re-read all the ads and signs on the tall buildings.

Then he saw a sign that read 'Lone Flora.'

Izuku stopped and cocked his head at it.

It was rather bland and didn't draw much attention like the other signs. It lacked any vibrant colors and was made of wood with unremarkable black lettering. The door it hung above was also plain. But it was made of steel and reinforced further with steel locks. But there wasn't even a door handle. Merely a simple sliding peephole.

The longer Izuku stared at the sign, he realized the words were an anagram.

One For All.

Izuku's heart skyrocketed.

He quickly shepherded the kids towards the door. He began to knock on it furiously, creating a loud banging noise. It didn't take long for footsteps to approach through the other side. Soon, the cover to the peephole slid open.

Izuku's breath hitched when he was met with sky blue eyes.

“Sorry we’re closed right now,” the man said. “Come back in the morning.”

“I’m here for One For All,” Izuku blurted out immediately.

The man’s eyes flickered with recognition. Now, he gazed at Izuku far differently. Like he needed help. The man looked to the side of Izuku, checking to see if anyone was behind him. Then he shut the slider and began to unlock the door.

Izuku stepped back and he felt his feet tingle with adrenaline. With a loud rusty sound, the steel door crept opened.

Awaiting him was a man larger than anyone he’s ever seen. Izuku struggled to stop himself from staring crazily. The man possessed striking canary blond hair and robust facial features. The look in his bright blue eyes was as warm as the sun.

“Hurry inside,” The large man quickly said.

The stranger glanced around out the door and then looked down to Izuku. He opened his mouth to speak but then stumbled. His eyes sparked with curiosity as he laid eyes on the five tiny children who were all gawking at him.

“Oh,” The man said. He blinked several times. “This is new.”

Izuku rubbed Katsuma’s head when the introverted boy hid behind his leg.

The other kids, however, were gasping in awe. They all huddled around the man and began poking at him.

Kota stepped forward and pointed up at the man. He tilted his head and asked, “Are you a Sasquatch? You’re huge and hairy like one!”

The man spluttered. Izuku quickly pulled Kota back and apologized to the man for him. He sheepishly smiled as he walked in, herding the children as he went.

When they were safely inside, the door slammed shut behind them. A new, cozy warmth greeted them like they were all longtime friends. The smell of freshly baked bread wrapped around the atmosphere. And the sound of affectionate laughter was everywhere.

Izuku stopped and drank in the sight. He didn’t know exactly what he was expecting but this wasn’t entirely it.

The secret hideaway was built like an izakaya. Red lanterns hung overhead and the walls were coated with old photographs. They were placed closely together, filling in the wooden walls like puzzle pieces. Off to the side was a long bar section and behind it was rows and rows of alcohol.

However, what threw Izuku off the most were just how many people there were.

There were dozens of people here, all with bright characteristics like nice smiles and sweet voices. Men and women were stationed around casually at wooden izakaya tables having a

drink of beer. Some were eating from plates of food stacked like mountains. Others were gathered in cliques playing cards as they laughed and talked.

But most had their eyes glued to the one television that was mounted in the corner.

Izuku looked up to the TV too, curious what caught everyone's attention.

But his heart skipped when he saw his old home on the screen.

The once beautiful large collection of skyscrapers was singed black at the bottom. Where the parking garage used to be there was now absolutely nothing. It looked like an empty black void. It was charred as if someone set off a large bomb and ran away.

The news showed a clip of the actual fire and the roaring flames. Izuku offhandedly thought it looked beautiful, like a dazzling inferno swallowing up all the sickness inside of that building.

When they cut back to real time, there was a thick crowd gathered around the scene.

Everyone was wearing expressions of shock and wonder. Things like this didn't happen frequently in Tokyo, and when they did, they were the center of attention for months. Countless people were snapping photos while the police put yellow tape around the perimeter.

In front of the chaos stood a news reporter. She was graced with long black hair that swayed with the wind.

"The Governor of Tokyo's privately owned apartment complex has gone up in flames," the news reporter said into the mic seriously. "Some accounts are saying it was a likely case of arson. Luckily, the fire department was able to make it to the scene before the damage was too great. No one inside the building was harmed from the fire. Local authorities say that the Governor has decided he will be leading a private investigation and will not be involving law enforcement."

Izuku knew what that meant.

Vipers and Yakuza were going to handle this.

Izuku's eyes then scanned around. He looked at the crowd a bit wearily now.

He was slightly fearful that someone could recognize him. There was no doubt Tomura and Chisaki put out word through the underground that he was officially a runaway Viper—and runaway Vipers were always dragged back home. One way or another.

The large man who had let them in the building smiled at Izuku kindly. He gestured for Izuku to follow him through the crowd.

As Izuku followed behind the large man, all the kids crowded closely to his legs. They stared at all the people in quiet amazement. It was to be expected. They hadn't met other people who were not Vipers. This many new faces was probably both exciting and frightening.

Izuku kept his hand on Katsuma's head. The tiny boy clutched onto his leg with every step.

When they reached the bar across the way, the large man whispered something to the bartender. The bartender then glanced at Izuku once. He was immediately alarmed by Izuku's disheveled appearance.

The bartender speedily hurried to the backroom behind the bar.

A few short moments later, out walked Nana.

Izuku's breath caught. She was gorgeous.

Her large, deep purple eyes were kinder than anything Izuku had experienced. It was as if she was hugging him just by gazing at him.

She was fairly older now than in the photo. But he could tell it was her based on the tiny beauty mark below her lip. There were some aged wrinkles around her mouth, eyes, and lips. In her thick black hair were streaks of white. But her beauty was still as striking if not more refined now.

She gazed at Izuku without fear as she approached him. When she drew near, the sweet smell of peaches graced him.

Izuku was almost starstruck. Something inside of his chest swelled at the sight of her.

She smiled at him and tilted her head.

"Hello there," Nana said, with a voice lovelier than a thousand moons. "Nice to meet you. I'm Nana. I'm guessing based on your appearance you need to get out of town quickly. What's your name?"

Izuku blinked.

"I—" He tried to speak but suddenly all the emotions he'd been shoving down forced their way up. He blinked rapidly, surprised by the sudden pounding in his chest. But the longer he looked at Nana he felt himself grow more and more vulnerable. "I-I'm—M-My name—" Izuku choked.

He slapped a hand over his mouth in surprise. Nana's eyes grew softer.

When he tried and failed again, this time Eri spoke up. She said, "He's Izuku!"

Nana smiled down at all the kids and gave Izuku a delicate glance. "Well, thank you. What's your name?"

"I'm Eri," the small girl said.

Izuku quickly pulled himself together. He blinked back the tears and forced down his emotions.

“Ye-Yes, I’m Izuku,” he said quickly. He awkwardly laughed and pushed at his tired eyes. “Um, I’m here because th-they really need your help.”

Nana seemed surprised at that. She then glanced at all the kids in his oversized sweaters. She waved at Katsuma who hid behind Izuku’s leg more.

“I see,” Nana said a bit seriously. She looked at the large man and said, “Yagi. Can you take them to the booth to get comfy? I think I need to talk privately with Izuku for a while.”

The large man now identified as Yagi nodded. He squatted down and all the kids gasped. He smiled friendly and saluted them.

“Do you kids wanna get some food?” Yagi asked in an excited tone.

That seemed to catch all the kids’ attention. Even Katsuma. Katsuma looked up at Izuku unsure, and Izuku nodded and patted his head. He pushed Katsuma lightly towards Yagi. Katsuma shyly smiled and walked up to Yagi with the other kids.

“Yes!” Hana said happily. She clasped her hands together and her brown eyes shone. “I’m really hungry. We haven’t eaten all day ‘cause ‘zuku said we didn’t have any time, but he would give us food once we got to our other family’s place.”

Yagi and Nana stole a glance at Izuku.

“Well, surprise! You’re here!” Yagi said with a large grin. He widely opened his arms and did some movements of jazz hands. “Let’s get you guys some food. Who likes ice cream?”

A choir of tiny ‘me!’ chimed.

Izuku smiled weakly as Yagi led the kids to the other side of the izakaya. They all slid inside a comfy, large red booth with the kids bouncing on the cushion. Yagi bounced playfully with them as he began to ask them what they each wanted to eat.

Izuku observed with unmoving eyes. He was unable to tear his gaze away.

A warm, soothing hand rubbed his shoulder to ask for his attention. Izuku looked at Nana and it was here that Izuku realized he had been crying.

Nana wiped away a tear for him.

“Let’s get you cleaned up first, then we can talk,” Nana said gently.

ɯɯɯ

The first thing they did was have Nana help him out of his lace blouse. She didn’t ask any questions as Izuku took off his hoodie to show her the ruined, expensive top.

All the crusted blood made the buttons stiff, and she ended up needing to cut him out of it. As the knife shredded through the fabric, Izuku finally felt like he could breathe. Never in his

life had he been more relieved to be out of an article of clothing. It was like shedding old skin.

He sourly gazed at it once he was freed. The pattern of vipers on it brought forth an unwelcome emotion. All he could hear was Tomura's confession about trying to set him up to marry Chisaki. Then he felt Chisaki's boney fingers rake down the buttons on his back.

The pain in his chest tripled. He threw the ruined blouse in the trash bitterly.

After that, Izuku was given medical attention for his wounds and patched up well. Nana allowed him to shower downstairs in a secret compartment that held rows and rows of tiny, skinny beds. Izuku presumed this is where people could spend the night as a pitstop before they left.

Nana gave him plain dark gray sweats to change into.

When he was settled in, Nana took him to a small room upstairs in the izakaya and locked the door. They took a seat at the only table inside that was directly below a warm, yellow light. She slid him a cup of tea and placed a heated blanket over his shaking shoulders.

"It's wonderful to meet you, Izuku," Nana said happily. She gazed at him up and down. "You have a nice name."

"It's wonderful to meet you too," Izuku replied. He bowed slightly. "Sorry for popping up so suddenly."

"That's alright. It's what my job is," Nana reassured. She then looked a bit more serious and calmly placed her hand on the table. "I have to ask. I don't usually like to assume, but those five kids can't all be yours."

"They're not," Izuku answered. "They're my…"

Brothers and sisters was the first thing he thought to say. But then he stopped. These kids weren't his kin. Not in the same way Aoyama, Ibara and Jin had been. They didn't belong with their discarded family. They were wanted and there was a home for them elsewhere in this hellish world.

Izuku cleared his throat and redirected his answer.

"They're missing kids that were kidnapped about five years ago," Izuku said firmly. "I need your help to bring them back to their families."

He reached down to his duffle bag and pulled out his tiny notebook. With shaking fingers, he opened it, despite the alarm that was now on Nana's face. He flipped through the pages and slid the notebook across from her.

"I-I have already located most of their families, I think," Izuku said a bit erratically. "Everyone is mostly still searching for their children. Pretty much all but one family was traceable. That was Katsuma's family. He's the shy one that was hugging my leg earlier. B-

But I think maybe his family is just more private. I have their info and such right here for you so you can have a starting point—"

"—Wait," Nana cut off his nervous ramble. She held a hand up and leaned away, entirely shocked. "Wait, wait. We have to pause." She pointed to the door, bewildered. "Those are missing children out there?"

"Yes," Izuku confirmed. He pleaded desperately with his eyes. "All of them were stolen as infants from separate hospitals about five years ago. I-I wrote down which hospital and everything. I have their old social security numbers—"

"Izuku. Hold on for a moment. Why are you not going to the police?" Nana asked wearily. "I feel like this is an issue for authorities. I don't serve in justice or reuniting people with long lost relatives. My service is for people who are on the run from dangerous people. Or people who can't go to the police. This feels…cut and dry. Missing kids go home."

"I can't go to the authorities," Izuku explained. His voice cracked and a lump swelled in his throat. He felt himself begin to clam up like always when it came to talk about how he was raised to outsiders. But he pushed past it by harnessing his desperation to get the kids to safety. "Those kids…they're…they were taken by The Viper Academy."

Familiarity echoed in Nana's eyes. She assessed him differently now.

Izuku immediately picked up on the distrust.

"Do you know that operation?" Izuku asked carefully.

"I do," Nana replied quietly. She spoke in such a low whisper that Izuku barely heard her. "But how do you know about that place? That's extremely confidential information. Not too many people discover that info and live to tell the tale."

Izuku licked his lips. He went against his entire nature to say, "B-Because I was raised there."

With trembling fingers, Izuku pulled down the collar of the sweatshirt. He craned his neck and showed her his mark. 217.

Nana's eyes widened.

"I'm o-one of the top assassins raised there," Izuku confessed, and his voice cracked. "All those kids were supposed to be our next cohort of trainees—But they were sentenced to be executed last night by the head of the Shie Hassaikai. I stopped it before it could happen. Then I-I drove all the way here, non-stop. Those kids really need your help. I'll do anything."

Nana was fearful now, but not of him.

"You interfered with an order from the Shie Hassaikai?" She asked quietly.

"Yes," Izuku replied.

He lowered his head and looked at his scribbling in the notebook. He pushed it to her, desperate to make this work.

“The kids’ families might need help disappearing because of that,” Izuku said. “M-My brother, Tomura, he’s the head of the operations in Tokyo for the Vipers. He’s a level of ruthless I don’t think the underground has seen before. He might try to track down the families if I just dropped them off at the doorstep—and he would have no issue committing familicide five times over. So, I-I need your help in giving the families a second option.”

“The option to disappear,” Nana filled in, understanding what Izuku was suggesting.

“Yeah,” Izuku agreed shakily. “I know it’s a far reach but…but they might take it if it means they can be happy together as a family again. You can explain what happened as much as you see fit.”

“The families would most likely take it,” Nana reasoned. Her face grew stern, and she finally took the notebook in her hands. She skimmed through the information. “Five kids…let’s assume and say that’s two parents each and potentially an additional child. That’s about twenty people who I would have to shuffle around.”

Nana strummed her fingers on the table. She pursed her lips to the side.

“Okay,” Nana said solidly. “I’ll do it.”

Izuku’s heart leapt.

“Really?” Izuku exclaimed.

“Yes,” Nana replied. “This is an urgent issue with children’s lives in the balance. I’m willing to help out the best I can. What about you? You need help disappearing too, I’m guessing?”

Izuku paused. He looked at Nana, unsure.

“I…I didn’t give myself much thought,” Izuku whispered. He idly scratched at the surface of the table with a finger. “I only wanted to bring the kids here so they could be safe.”

“You should consider it,” Nana encouraged. She reached across the table and gently held his hand. “You did a good thing. But I doubt the Vipers will let you go that easy, especially if the Shie Hassaikai is involved. You could be killed for doing this.”

Izuku nodded hollowly.

If only Nana knew how much trouble he was really in. Death would be too simple of a punishment.

He doubted that Tomura would kill him. Tomura viewed him as an extension of himself. Tomura killing him would be like Tomura willingly sawing off his own arm. His spiteful, controlling brother was more likely to throw Izuku in a glass box for the rest of his life than ever murder him.

But Izuku knew, box or not, there would be some sort of punishment awaiting him. It was going to be a mind shattering one that would ensure Izuku would no longer fight back.

Next, Izuku considered Chisaki.

In a roundabout way, he gave Chisaki the five lives of Vipers like the man demanded—and then some. The only issue left with Chisaki was the fact he set those conditions. Chisaki was a spoiled brat who wanted his *prize* one way or another. And Chisaki very clearly wanted Katsuki dead for what he'd done.

But then there was the matter of Katsuki.

Izuku could feel the cut on his neck sting a bit. Somehow, despite his own heartbreak, he still felt a protective urge call to him. Could he really leave knowing Chisaki was going to hunt and kill Katsuki?

A tug in his heart told him, no. He couldn't.

"Think it over," Nana said when Izuku went quiet. She squeezed his hand reassuringly. "I know it's a big decision to start over a new life. But you should really consider it given everything."

"I'll think it over," Izuku responded quietly. He tried to wrench his mind away from thoughts of Katsuki but found that he couldn't. He replayed the hurt look in Katsuki's eyes over and over again.

"Happy to hear that," Nana said. She then inhaled deeply and winced. "There is…one small hurdle, logistically."

Izuku grew weary. "What would that be?"

"The most people I usually take at a time is fifteen people max per month," Nana explained apprehensively. "Any more than that and I begin to risk raising red flags legally. I have to go through a lot of under the table hoops in order to craft new, fake identifications such as passports. And it takes a lot of work to set people up in their new life."

Izuku held his breath.

"I'm already going to be pushing it with a potential twenty people," Nana continued. "And given that this task requires extra effort on my end by locating people instead of them coming to me, I will be extremely busy. That means I likely won't be able to get around to helping you for another two months or so. Is that okay?"

Two months.

Izuku gazed off to the side. He felt caught at a crossroads.

"That's…okay," Izuku decided indifferently. "I can wait two months. I'll have made up my mind by then. I-I'll come meet you if I want to go."

“Okay,” Nana replied happily. “Are you sure you can lay low for that time and meet me in the next city? You might have to keep it moving in order to stay away from the Vipers and Yakuza.”

“Yes. I can do that. Okinawa, right?” Izuku asked.

“Right.” Nana leaned in and tenderly assessed him, “I usually stay in the same city for about a month or get a move on once I hit my maximum of people who come to me. But if you meet me in Okinawa in that window of time, I can get you set up. I’ll save you a slot. But if you don’t come, I’m going to assume either something happened, or you didn’t want to go.”

“O-Okay,” Izuku said. “Thank you so much. This means the world.”

“No need to thank me, this is what I do,” Nana said strongly. She sat up straight and stood up. “We’ll leave directly tomorrow night. I’ll embark with some of my team, and we’ll get this all sorted out. You can count on me. Now, let’s go back out with the kids and get you food as well. You have been through a lot.”

This was the first time since Katsuki that Izuku really saw kindness.

He gazed at her, and it was as if a bright light shone around her head.

She held her hand out for him, and Izuku hesitantly took it. It was warm and loving. He held on tightly to her as she helped him up. She wrapped her arm around his shoulders, and they began to walk out to the izakaya.

When they walked back into the crowd, Izuku felt overwhelming relief.

Across the way, Yagi was entertaining the children. There were straws poking out his nose and he was making wild animal noises. Every single one of the kids laughed. Even Katsuma. Their eyes were sparkling as they tried their best to clap in the layers of oversized sweaters.

When Nana and Izuku joined the kids and Yagi at the booth, they blended in with the convo.

More savory food was brought to the table and Katsuma shuffled into Izuku’s side automatically. Izuku hugged him back affectionately.

As they basked in this comfort, Izuku felt a glimmer of hope for his future. It was small, but it was there.

Maybe with Nana’s help he could finally be normal. She really was the key. She was like a remedy to allow Izuku to be cleansed of all his darkness.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When they went to bed that night, Nana helped Izuku push together five of the beds.

They gathered the kids inside, and found enough blankets to pile up on top of them. All the kids were happy to be in bed. The comfort of the mattress plus a full belly put them to sleep

immediately.

Izuku took a bed directly next to theirs. As he climbed in, his eyes scanned the basement. There were other people in the room now. Across the way, three people were curled up on different beds. Izuku presumed that these must be people who came searching for Nana and also needed help disappearing.

She really was a busy person, and Izuku wondered what these peoples' stories were. What were they running from? Or more specifically, who? He felt a bit more normal seeing this. It seemed like it was human nature to try to survive, even if it was by a thin thread of hope.

As Izuku's head hit the pillow, all the events of the last two days finally weighed down on him.

Mainly, the body count. For the first time in his life, he didn't have his book to tally the deaths. And they lingered on his skin as if they were imprinting inside of him.

He tried to push the somberness away.

All he wanted was to finally get a good night's rest. But every time he closed his eyes he saw a different face. First it was Katsuki's. Then it was Tomura's. Then Chisaki's. Jin's. Ibara's. Aoyama's. And the near twenty two others of his siblings that he murdered in cold blood.

With every new face he saw, they all lined up in a row. Everyone's expression was twisted in either pain or anger.

Or in Katsuki's case—both.

Izuku eventually gave up on resting.

He sighed and shifted onto his side, facing the kids.

Izuku blankly gazed across the way. He focused in on the dark corner behind the children. He half expected the ghost of Hiryu to be looming there. This was usually the time it would show itself: whenever he was feeling cornered and anxious.

But nothing came.

The inside of his mind was eerily lonely.

Izuku understood now that there would be no more ghosts. Ghosts were born from the ugly mixture of guilt and regret—and Izuku barely regretted what he did. He would do it again, if given the chance.

And because of that lack of remorse, Izuku could see things clearly. The first thing he processed was how his instinct to survive taking Hiryu's form was no coincidence.

Hiryu and Tomura had always been opposing forces. Truly two powerhouses that were always at odds because Hiryu *hated* Tomura. He loathed how he controlled Izuku. He detested how he treated them. He despised Tomura down to his last, spiteful breath.

But more importantly, Hiryu was the first person to ever *warn* Izuku against Tomura.

At first, Izuku simply thought all the snide remarks Hiryu's ghost would say were just echoes of his late brother's likely opinions. It made sense that Hiryu's ghost would bash Tomura. Or that it would butt in and point out Tomura's hypocrisy, lies, and selfishness.

But this whole time it was really his mind cautioning him against his big brother.

Katsuki was right all along.

His body had been severely warning him against who was threatening his life this whole time. It was trying desperately to get him to realize who the person hurting him was. Izuku was just unable to see it through his layers of shame and guilt Tomura instilled in him.

But now, he saw it all clearly: all Tomura did was abuse him.

A bitter tear slid out of Izuku's eye as he finally accepted this truth.

ᔓᔓᔓ

After a long night of battling his own thoughts, Izuku was able to get a tiny bit of rest.

It was mostly him resting his eyes. But whatever worked, he would take it.

He shook off the deep fatigue he was beginning to feel in his bones and pushed forward once more. He was thankful that there was adrenaline still coursing through his veins, and he was bitterly grateful that Tomura always pushed his endurance capabilities.

Izuku walked upstairs to the first floor of the izakaya in his sweats. He gazed around and noted how the izakaya was far different in the morning compared to how it was at night. There were significantly less people gathered around and in the background the subtle sound of smooth jazz played.

Nana was sitting at a corner table, scribbling something down with a black duffle bag at her feet.

Off behind the bar was Yagi, hunched over, carefully powdering pancakes. Wrapped around his neck was a yellow apron that read 'don't kill the chef' as he prepared multiple plates chock-full of breakfast food.

When the smell of blueberries and syrup wafted into Izuku's nose, it triggered his hunger. A loud, embarrassing growl erupted from him that could've been mistaken for a bear.

Yagi and Nana looked up at the sound, directing their attention to him. They both stifled laughs and grinned. Izuku nervously covered his stomach as if that would muffle the sound.

"Well, good morning!" Nana greeted Izuku happily. "Someone's hungry!"

Izuku nervously laughed. "Good morning to you too."

“Come sit!” Nana smiled gently and waved him over.

Izuku walked over to her shyly and took a seat next to her. She gazed at him with soft apprehension.

“So how did you sleep?” Nana asked.

“Ah, not very well if I am being honest,” Izuku answered sheepishly. He shrugged his shoulders and smiled at her. “But how did you sleep?”

“I slept well for the most part.” She leaned back in her chair and folded her hands on her lap. “I mainly stayed awake making sure to cross check some of the information you have jotted down. Luckily, you’re very thorough! I think I can do this for certain with the right people. I made several calls and some crew members are going to meet me at the dock at nightfall.”

Izuku’s eyes lit up. “That’s amazing news! Thank you so much again for doing this.”

“It’s no problem at all,” Nana replied back joyfully. “I told you before. This is what I do. Oh, speaking of.” She then lifted up the black duffle bag next to her feet and handed it over to Izuku. “I packed this for you, and this bag is specially made to be bulletproof. It should help you with the next two months—if you decide to come with me that is. If not, then it’s yours to keep.”

Izuku curiously took the bag. It was extremely heavy and he couldn’t immediately tell what was inside. He unzipped it a bit eagerly but his heart stopped at the sight of its contents.

Stuffed to the brim were several wads of yen, non perishable food, and clothing about his size.

Izuku instantly zipped the bag back up and whipped his head to Nana.

“I can’t take your money,” Izuku said, guilt heavy on his shoulders. He quickly shoved the bag towards her and lowered his head. “I-I should really be the one paying you. This is too much. I will try to manage on my own the best I can—”

Nana lightly pushed the bag back in Izuku’s lap.

Izuku’s hands began trembling slightly, shocked by how kind she was.

“Please. Take it,” Nana insisted. Her eyes grew as tender as if she knew Izuku his whole life. “If you really are one of the kids who was sold to that Academy, then I want to help you the best I can. I heard a lot of whispers about what happens inside of there. It’s a miracle you have retained even an ounce of your humanity. Even if you decide against using my services, you deserve to have the option. My job is to help people the best I can.”

Izuku didn’t know quite what to say.

How could someone be so loving to someone they didn’t know?

Izuku settled for saying “Thank you” but those two words didn’t feel like they were enough. He wanted to express gratitude as endless as the stars in the sky. But how did he do that?

“Also, I made a call for you,” Nana informed. “If you need a safe place to lay low for a while to recuperate, I found a perfect location. It’s in a small town called Shinonsen in Mikata District. All you have to do is drop my current alias at a bath house called Midnight Sento to a woman named Kayama Nemuri.”

Nana then wrote down the name and location on a page in his notebook. She ripped it out and handed it to Izuku with the utmost seriousness.

“She’s my affiliate and she said she can try her best to look after you. Okay?”

“O-Okay. Thank you again,” Izuku said, still shocked. He took the piece of paper, studying the neat hand writing on it in awe. “If it’s alright, may I ask you a question?”

“Of course, Izuku.”

“Why do you help people so much? This is…so nice. What do you get out of it?”

Nana gave a light, airy laugh and smirked at Izuku. “You really were raised at that Academy. Do you think every action has a selfish motive behind it?”

“Sorry!” Izuku spluttered. He shook his head quickly and waved his hands. “I didn’t mean to imply you were selfish—”

“I’m only messing with you,” Nana teased with a chuckle.

She then leaned back in her chair and looked at the surface of the wooden table. She studied the scratches on it like it told a story. Then like the sky, her bright expression slowly faded into dimness.

“But. You’re right,” Nana whispered. “I have a small, selfish motive behind all of this. Do you really want to know?”

“Yes,” Izuku said quietly. “I-If that’s alright.”

“It is,” Nana said. Her smile was gone now. “About thirty years ago, I had my heart broken. My only daughter had gotten married to the love of her life. She was his whole world; I’d never seen someone so in love. He doted on her every whim and they were a perfect match for each other. I was so excited to be a grandmother when they had their first born, and even more excited when they told me they were expecting a second.”

Nana paused. She sucked at her teeth and lowered her head a bit.

“But,” Nana whispered. “My beautiful daughter passed away giving birth to their second born.”

“I’m so sorry,” Izuku tried to comfort.

“It’s okay,” Nana said. She tried to smile but it was like her triumphant glow was fractured now. “Her husband…He never recovered from losing her. He tried to patch himself up with all sorts of distracting things. Excessive traveling, partying, drinking, then soon illegal mahjong gambling. The depressive hole he fell into was so deep no one could save him from himself.”

Izuku furrowed his brow.

How sad.

“He ended up losing all his money and going flat broke,” Nana said with a heavy sigh. “Because of that, I ended up taking the kids in with me. I was more than happy to watch over my grandchildren. It was like looking at two little miracles who were a reflection of my late daughter. I took care of them for about a year. Then one day my son in law came back, but only for the youngest.”

Izuku frowned. “Only for the youngest?”

“Yup,” Nana nodded dully. “I knew something was off, but I couldn’t tell what. He was calmer, like he decided something. I thought at first he finally decided to bond with his youngest child because that’s what he told me. And like a fool, I believed him. The next day I went to visit them both with fresh fruit. But when I got there, I found him hastily packing a suitcase of money and clothes to flee town. I asked him to give me back the baby if he was going to move, but—”

Nana’s face crumbled.

The age lines on her face became more pronounced as she lowered her head.

“—The baby wasn’t *there*,” Nana whispered dreadfully. “Little did I know when I gave him back his son, he had festered a deep resentment for the child for taking away his wife. He told me my grandson was gone and called him cursed. A-And that bastard had too much money in those bags for someone who was bankrupt for the last year. I began to put two and two together—and it was a sickening realization what type of evil he committed.”

Izuku stiffened.

Ice began to sickle in his veins at what Nana was hinting at. Her grandson met a similar fate as him, but somehow upon hearing this, he felt worse for whoever it was.

“I tried to go to the police, but it was no use,” Nana said desperately. “There wasn’t enough evidence to detain him and stop him from leaving. So, he vanished from town. Shortly after, he was marked dead in public records but I didn’t believe it. I think he was absorbed into the shadows with a new identity.”

Nana curled her fist on the table.

“I filed a missing person’s report for my grandson,” She said angrily. “But the police work so slow and are so *useless*. After that I began searching on my own. I tried to track down what

he could have done with that poor child. That's when I came across whispers of this underground domain. People told me that my grandson was likely far gone, and I would never see him again."

A blazed, furious look in her eyes ignited.

"After that, I began learning more about the horrors of what really lurks beneath the surface," Nana spat. She regained her composure. In place of her sadness was now fury. "Yakuza, terrible gangs, political corruption, black markets and all kinds of other vile monstrosities. I-I couldn't stand by and do *nothing*. So I began to create my own network to counteract it: a way for people to leave the darkness they were trapped in."

Small, tiny tremors began to quake in Nana's fingers. Izuku reached out to grab her hand and steadied her.

She let out a shaky exhale and gazed at Izuku. Deep, unhealed sadness swirled in her eyes.

"To this day, I don't know where my grandson is," Nana concluded sadly. "But, I have a selfish hope that maybe one day, he will walk through those doors. And he'll ask for help to escape whatever darkness his father sold him into, even though it's been so long."

"What was his name?" Izuku asked quietly.

"Tenko," Nana answered. "But I fear his father might have said his name was something different. He always said Tenko didn't suit him because it sounded too nice for someone who killed his own mother. I have found no Tenko in all my years of searching."

Izuku searched his memory but found no Tenko either.

After that conversation, Izuku couldn't get the name Tenko out of his mind.

He hoped one day Nana could be reunited with her grandson, but he knew that was unlikely to happen. If he really was sold into the underground there's no telling where the boy was now. He might not even be in Japan or even alive.



The rest of the day went smoothly and Izuku watched Nana perform in her element. Boat loads of people came in and out of the izakaya, and Izuku curiously observed from his seat in the corner.

So many people adored Nana it seemed. Their eyes would light up like the moon when they saw her. Then their demeanor would soften as if everything was alright in the world. Others who came in were clearly hiding from someone. They kept their heads down and quietly thanked Nana as they shuffled down in the basement area.

While Izuku watched all of this, he learned Yagi was set to be Nana's future successor. He was going to be passed the torch next in helping keep this long connected network of people

together. It was as if they were all guardian angels, and Izuku couldn't help but be inquisitive.

Half way through the day, Yagi left for the store. When he came back, in his hands were bags full of winter clothes for Izuku and all of the kids in their respective sizes. He even bought the kids backpacks for their travels.

Izuku's heart clutched a bit when he noticed Katsuma's clothes were the smallest.

They packed up their new clothes and Izuku consolidated all his items into his new duffle bag. He stacked the money Nana gave him in tightly to the bottom and then carefully loaded each gun with full ammo.

When he put on his new clothes, he had to stare at his reflection.

He wore loosely fitting dark black joggers, a black sweater and red dark running shoes.

When he pulled on his olive green winter coat, Izuku felt like a different person.

He tightly slung the bullet-proof duffle bag across his back.

Nana began to gather all the kids one by one. She neatly aligned them in a row as Izuku, and Yagi helped zip them into their winter coats.

Then when nightfall came, a sudden pain captured Izuku.

It was like it was already waiting inside of him. It only needed the right opportunity to rear its ugly head. The sharpness in his chest doubled then tripled until he felt it manifest itself as tears in his eyes. He paused while putting on the kids' backpacks when he didn't quite know what it was.

But it became overwhelming when he pulled a hat over Katsuma's fluffy head of hair.

Katsuma's big, brown eyes gazed up at him like he was the world. It was here Katsuma lifted his arms up, and Izuku knew why he was in so much pain. He was going to miss Katsuma more than he should.

Izuku smiled through the agony and picked up the tiny boy.

ᔓᔓᔓ

They made their way down to the large port in Osaka. There were endless rows of large boats, thick crowds of people, and countless cargo containers in sight.

Izuku observed as a larger than life crane lifted up one metal container and dropped it onto a white steam boat. It hit the surface with a loud, metallic thud that made all the kids gasp. In the background seagulls gawked and rolling waves added to the chaotic ambiance.

All the kids began pointing and tugging at his pants' legs. They asked him what everything was and where the boats were going. Izuku didn't have an answer, so he made up something

to keep them occupied.

He smiled at their bubbling curiosity. They had never seen boats this big, and Eri said they were like giants wading in the water smiling down at them. Some boats looked like simple cruise ships. Others were speed boats and some were fishing boats. The latter seemed to be Kota's favorites.

After they walked down the wooden dock for a while, they came across what Izuku guessed to be Nana's boat.

It was medium sized, painted white and docked in a discreet corner of the bay. On the side of it were the words 'Lone Flora' written in cursive lettering. At the bottom, Izuku could see lines of round windows. Inside of them he could peek in and observe the living quarters that were below deck.

On the top of the boat was a crew of people barking orders at one another, preparing to set sail. One of the crew members spotted Nana, and then glanced at the rest of them. They waved at them with foreign friendliness that Izuku hadn't ever experienced. Izuku waved back, encouraging all the kids to do the same.

Katsuma shyly waved and then clung to Izuku tighter.

They walked up the pier to the boat and then made their way up the stairs to the deck. Once they were all gathered on the boat, Nana turned to him.

"Okay," She said. "This is it. Anything you want to say before going? Or was there anything you forgot?"

Izuku began to nervously jitter his leg. He hugged Katsuma a bit tighter as he gazed down at all the children. They looked up at him too, all so innocent and smiling.

His heart began pounding with that pain in his chest.

This really would be the last time he saw them.

"Hana and Tamashiro are a bit more quiet," Izuku said nervously. "Th-They're more independent. Hana has a tendency to eat and wipe her hands on her pants so she gets dirtier quicker. Tamashiro sometimes forgets to voice when he's hungry and he eats his boogers instead. Just tell him not to and he'll feel embarrassed and stop."

Nana smiled at him sadly, but didn't interrupt.

"Eri and Kota like to talk a lot so make sure to ask them a lot of questions," Izuku explained with a shaky laugh. "They can talk for hours and they also like playing with the other kids. If they're too rough with each other ju-just correct them. They don't know any better yet, especially Kota. He thinks it's good to push other people. A-And Katsuma likes to sleep with the lights on. He's really shy and gets scared easily—"

"—You've never said goodbye to anyone before." Nana touched his shoulder lightly. "Have you?"

Izuku was hit with a ton of bricks.

This was his first real goodbye—and he had not a single clue how to do it. He never experienced this before. Hiryu had abruptly left, and Izuku hadn't even said goodbye to Katsuki correctly. Every attempted farewell he experienced was sudden or half done, leaving behind several loose ends.

Izuku shook his head and the inside of his chest crumbled.

"No," Izuku whispered. "I haven't."

"Let's try to make this easier on you then," Nana said.

She squatted down to the children's level and smiled.

Nana then announced that they would be going on a field trip with her to meet their new family. All the kids seemed excited. Their adventure so far sparked their curiosity after being isolated for so long.

Nana began grand gestures and then told all the kids to say goodbye to Izuku. They did. They each gave enthusiastic waves and jumped up and down about seeing more family.

All except Katsuma that is. Katsuma's happiness stopped. He stared Izuku in the eye.

"You're not coming too, 'zuku?" Katsuma questioned in a small voice.

"I'm not," Izuku forced himself to say. His chest pinched tightly with heartbreak. "I'm sorry. I'm going to go somewhere else."

"Okay. But when will you be back? Are you meeting us there?" Katsuma pressed.

He kissed the top of Katsuma's forehead and smiled sadly at him. He decided to be honest. Katsuma was owed the truth and he deserved to start his new life without any loose ends.

"I'm sorry, Katsuma," Izuku said quietly. "You're going to be with your real family. They've missed you very much. Y-You won't see me again after this. This is the last time we'll be together."

The confused, distressed sound Katsuma made broke Izuku's heart. His large eyes watered and he shook his head as if he didn't understand what Izuku was saying.

"N-No, 'zuku, don't leave me," Katsuma begged. "Pl-Please don't leave me again."

"But you're going to go with your real family. I'm not your real f-family."

"You are. You're my *brother*—"

"—I'm sorry, Katsuma," Izuku said in a broken whisper. "I'm *not*."

Nana wearily looked between them and her watch. “We have to start getting a move on. I’m so sorry.”

Izuku tried his best to hand Katsuma over to Nana, but Katsuma fought against him.

Katsuma began wailing loudly for everyone in the vicinity to hear. He clung on tighter and didn’t let go.

Izuku’s heart strings were pulled so taut that they snapped in two. It took a great deal of effort to peel Katsuma’s small arms from around his neck. It hurt so much to make him let go. But Katsuma had to—for the sake of his life he needed to be freed from Izuku.

Izuku sobbed as he forcefully pushed the boy into Nana’s hands.

Katsuma called his name as he stretched his arms back out to him. He reached for Izuku, with tears streaming down his eyes.

Izuku couldn’t do this. He could commit many, unspeakable things, but this was not one.

He screwed his eyes shut as Katsuma called his name over and over again.

With every call to him, Katsuma sounded increasingly confused and it *burned* his ears. Izuku’s heart begged him to go back and comfort Katsuma in his arms. But he knew he couldn’t. He was a sinking ship and Katsuma needed to get on this lifeboat to safety.

Nana cradled the thrashing boy in her arms the best she could, but it was difficult.

Izuku turned on his heels quickly and fled. This was too much for him.

He heard Katsuma’s cries grow louder and louder as he hurried off the boat. Once he finally was on the pier again, he looked up.

In the distance, Katsuma was gaping at him. His face was full of hurt, betrayal and confusion. He clung helplessly to Nana with one hand and kept reaching out back to Izuku with the other. He looked so puzzled, and Izuku didn’t know what to do. He hadn’t considered this would be the hardest part of his mission.

The boat began to depart. The crew unhooked the ropes and started the engine.

Slowly but surely, they took off into the night.

Katsuma kept crying. His small hand switched from stretching out to Izuku, to sadly waving goodbye.

That was all it took for Izuku to finally break down. He waved goodbye too as the boat started to gain speed, going off into the beautiful ocean.

Izuku waved goodbye and so did Katsuma. They did this until they could no longer see the other.

Once all Izuku could see was a tiny dot on the water, his face crumbled. A hoarse sob choked its way out of his throat.

He had no clue goodbye could hurt this much.

ᔓᔓᔓ

It took several, long grueling moments for Izuku to stop crying.

Once he could no longer see the boat, he pulled his hood over his head and began to walk away from the pier.

As he walked, he wept. He let the emotions flow freely, unashamed for having them. He felt and welcomed the intense pain of separation inside of his chest. It was harrowing like a spear to the heart, but he let the agony work its way through his body.

All this time he had been focused on getting the kids out, he forgot he grew attached to them. Especially Katsuma.

Izuku entirely forgot to consider what it would be like to part ways with his little. He wondered if this is what saying goodbye was like. Was it always such a painful process? He suddenly didn't blame Hiryu anymore for leaving without a word.

Izuku comforted himself with the reminder that this was for the better.

Even if the Yakuza or Vipers caught up with him now, all five of those kids would be long gone.

With that, Izuku was able to keep his head up in the dense crowd.

He pulled out the folded piece of paper in his pocket.

He read the words 'Midnight Sento' that were scribbled in Nana's handwriting.

Izuku chewed at the side of his cheek. From here on out, Izuku understood he was going to have to make decisions for the sake of himself. There was no more Katsuma. No more kids. No more trying to fit in with a broken family that he never belonged to. There wasn't even Kacchan.

He was officially alone.

He decided that before he made any drastic decisions, he should go meet Nana's ally first. After a good rest he could finally decide on what to do with the mess he was in.

Izuku began walking, and pulled out the map that he was using once more.

He noted where the town Shinonsen was. It wasn't exactly close, but it wasn't too far off from Osaka. He could easily take a train up there and walk to the small town. But he needed to hurry before the last train of the night left out at 00:00.

Izuku began making his way towards the train station. But then he stopped when he realized he forgot Jin's katana in the car. He cursed slightly under his breath.

He stopped in the middle of the sidewalk, earning some grumbles from other citizens.

Should he go back for it?

Currently, all Izuku had were handguns and ammo. He'd been too much in a rush to grab another blade, which was the type of weapon he was most skilled with. One of the very first lessons Tomura taught him was that having both a blade and gun was essential on longer missions. Guns were only useful if they had ammo, and ammo always eventually ran out.

Blades, however, did not need reloading.

Given the amount of danger Izuku was in, he couldn't exactly rely on his limited supply of ammo to defend himself for two months.

Izuku pursed his lips. The smart thing to do would be to go get the katana.

He nodded to himself. He began walking in the direction of where he ditched the pink sports' car.

He was forced to take a slightly longer route. He left the car in the central heart of Osaka, Minami district. It was flashy enough that no one would bat an eye at a hot pink car sitting there for days. It was a digital fortress of neon ads on screens and lights similar to Tokyo.

Izuku began walking swiftly. He wanted to make sure he could get on the train before it left in the next two hours.

He ventured into the dense night market that was packed with warm bodies. Hundreds of individuals were shoulder to shoulder underneath the bright red lanterns. Booths from merchants aligned the narrow pathway as shouts promising tasty food spilled into the air. The savory street food filled his senses as he walked by, and the sound of small children giggling were in the back amongst the chaotic chatter.

Izuku held on tightly to the strap of his bag as the melody of wind chimes blew through. He could feel the crowd pulsing with elation, exhaustion and the temperature here was a bit thicker.

When he made it to the end of the long strip, it was like gasping for fresh air.

He then arrived at the parking garage at 22:40.

Once Izuku walked inside the dim building, he surveyed the area carefully.

It was quiet, and full of cars aligned neatly in rows. It should be safe, but he wasn't sure. A small tingle scratched at his ear, making some hairs on his arms rise. He quickly glanced behind him but found nothing.

The vastness of the parking garage echoed his footsteps as he walked to the third level. When he got up there, he saw the candy pink car exactly where he left it. He began to approach the vehicle but stopped halfway when he saw unusual movement.

A head peaked up from behind the car.

Soft blond locks came into view.

Izuku's heart sank.

He rushed to hide behind one of the large pillars in the parking lot as stealthily as possible. His heart began pounding loudly in his ears as he crouched low. He tried to make himself small.

The figure stood up to its full height—and it was Katsuki.

His eyes stretched wide in disbelief and every nerve commanded him to *run*. But his feet stayed rooted, unable to believe what he was seeing.

Katsuki brushed a hand through his hair and Izuku felt his heart skip a dreadful beat at the sight.

His murderous husband walked around the car to come into full view. He was wearing a red motorcycle jacket with a gray hood. His large hands were covered in black leather gloves that were embedded with rusted brass knuckles.

If Izuku squinted, he could see old blood stains on his jacket. On Katsuki's face was a pair of darkly tinted sunglasses and his black cargo pants were lined with multiple rows of pockets—full of weapons no doubt.

Izuku watched Katsuki closely, mesmerized a bit.

He really found him? *So soon*? He nearly couldn't believe it.

Katsuki pulled his backpack off his body and zipped it open. He reached in and pulled out a tiny item. Izuku immediately knew what it was: a tracking device. Katsuki used a finger to tip his sunglasses down to his nose. His burning red eyes scanned the device with razor sharpness.

Izuku silently observed Katsuki as he placed the chip on the belly of the car. He did it with expert handling like it wasn't his first time. He fiddled with it a bit. Then he smirked in a horribly handsome manner as it latched into place.

Izuku furrowed his brow.

It was incredible that Katsuki somehow located him before either the Yakuza or Vipers. But he couldn't comprehend how that was even possible? He beat *Tomura*, of all people, in the race to wring his neck.

Izuku was kicking himself a bit. He should have taken Katsuki deeply seriously whenever the man gloated about being good at tracking. Because he really was an expert hunter and Izuku was his current target.

When Katsuki cracked his knuckles, Izuku's survival instinct kicked in.

He decided very wisely to leave the katana. He would have to just find another blade elsewhere at this rate and hope he didn't run out of ammo.

Izuku began to back up and a small echo followed his subtle movement.

The sound bounced off the concrete walls of the dark parking lot. It was such a minuscule, non-alarming noise. But to the trained ear it sounded like someone trying to sneak away.

Immediately, Katsuki turned his head and Izuku ducked all the way behind the pillar.

Izuku held his breath.

Katsuki shifted on his feet.

Then the sound of the backpack being zipped up reached Izuku. He started to sweat nervously when heavy footsteps began to head in his direction. Hefty thud after hefty thud. But then they stopped.

Izuku waited.

He stayed deathly still as a bead of sweat rolled from off his brow down his temple.

He cut his eyes to the side and slowly inched his head to peek at the car again.

To his surprise, Katsuki wasn't there.

Izuku furrowed his brow, confused. He glanced around the area where the car was. Katsuki was entirely gone but Izuku hadn't heard him move. He craned his neck further and found no indication of Katsuki around the area. He looked up and he looked across the way.

Next, Izuku stayed as still as possible. He shifted to look the other direction around the pillar.

But when he turned his head, all he saw were red eyes, boring into him.

Izuku's heart skipped several beats and his whole body startled at the sheer closeness. Katsuki was crouching directly next to him. He sadistically smirked like a predator who finally cornered its prey.

"This is the part where you run from me," Katsuki whispered, breath gliding across Izuku's lips.

Izuku's veins surged with pure adrenaline.

Izuku took off and instantly Katsuki shot his hands out to seize both his wrists. Izuku tried to snatch himself out of the hold with all his might. But Katsuki's grasp was painfully firm.

Katsuki leered as Izuku began to struggle fiercely.

Izuku dropped his whole body to the ground, forcing Katsuki to fall with him. He kicked his legs up, hitting Katsuki straight in the stomach.

Katsuki choked out a loud gasp and his hold loosened. Using his legs, Izuku kicked Katsuki off of him and scrambled up right.

He took flight like he was gifted the ability of wind. He began running as fast as he could. Right behind was Katsuki, who wasted no time.

Izuku gritted his teeth as he surged forward, looking behind him only once. When he did lay eyes on Katsuki, Katsuki was as pissed off as the last time he saw him. If not more.

Katsuki then reached inside of his coat. Sharp, dark steel caught the dim light and Izuku's stomach dropped lower and lower. Katsuki took aim and fired off two bullets. Izuku zig-zagged the best he could in order to dodge. He hissed in pain as one searing bullet skinned him and the other one missed.

They reached the second floor going full speed and Izuku's eyes darted all around. He saw the ramp to the first floor, and he saw the stairwell. Izuku barreled in full speed into the stairwell door as two more bullets zipped past his head.

Izuku made it past the door and slammed it shut behind him. He raced to try to find the lock on the door—but his gut twisted when there wasn't one.

Shit.

A loud bang hit the door, and the sound rolled like thunder. Izuku's heart hammered as Katsuki immediately tried to kick the door open. Izuku let out a yell of effort as he pushed against the door to keep it shut. With every brutal kick Katsuki gave, Izuku jolted but didn't move.

Then suddenly Katsuki switched from kicking to pushing.

Izuku's eyes bulged wide at the sheer strength exerted. It was as if four men were heaving on the other side, coming straight for him. Izuku's arms began to shake as he harnessed all his will to hold the door shut.

But Katsuki was always stronger. Slowly the door moved in Katsuki's favor. Izuku's feet began sliding against the concrete and Katsuki began winning.

Izuku thought of a solution rapidly. He stopped pushing and immediately Katsuki stumbled in, nearly falling over. With rapid recovery, Katsuki moved to aim his weapon to take a shot. But he missed when Izuku crouched low to the ground and out of the line of fire.

Instantly, Izuku worked with haste. He punched Katsuki's midsection with all his strength, slamming his knuckles straight into a pressure point.

Katsuki staggered, grunting as he absorbed the painful attack.

He tried to grapple for Izuku, but Izuku was always faster. Izuku fluidly ducked through Katsuki's legs and whirled to kick him in the back in a succinct combo. Katsuki went tumbling forward, hitting the ground like a stone pillar that met its match.

Izuku turned and ran. He headed down the ramp to the first floor as fast as he possibly could.

Izuku glanced over his shoulder. He wanted to make sure there was decent distance between them. But Katsuki was nowhere to be seen—again.

Izuku's blood boiled with panic. He looked forward and began sweating out of sheer fear. He was beginning to comprehend that Katsuki out of sight meant nothing good. His husband was far stealthier than he ever gave him credit for.

Izuku was cursing over and over in his head. He should've never gone back for that stupid katana.

Right when he breached the first floor, the boom of a revving engine bounced on all corners of the parking garage. It echoed like eerie laughter floating around him. Then following the noise was the loud sound of tires burning against concrete.

The two sounds closed-in disturbingly quick, wasting no time. It took less than ten seconds for blinding headlights to shine behind him.

Izuku kept running as he looked back.

It was a vision straight out of hell. Katsuki was blazing towards him at full speed on his red motorcycle with a gun.

Izuku kicked it in gear.

He hit the highest speed he's ever run. He darted straight out of the parking lot as Katsuki gained distance.

Izuku stumbled out onto the sidewalk, knocking over several civilians who were all simply trying to enjoy their night. He yelled out apologies to people he zoomed past. Crowds of pedestrians all gasped and yelled at him as he ducked and weaved between all their bodies.

Katsuki skidded out onto the road. He weaved in and out of the cars, breaking the speed limit way past what was acceptable. Multiple car horns beeped at him as he ran a red light. Izuku kept his feet pounding against the concrete. He looked to the side and saw a blur of scarlet right on his tail.

Katsuki was catching up unnervingly fast.

But Izuku noted how Katsuki wasn't shooting. Instead, he was trying to get close for a clear shot.

That's when Izuku remembered something about his husband. Katsuki was never keen on shooting a seemingly innocent civilian. Yakuza and Yakuza related affiliates? Sure. But Katsuki never killed people he didn't find to be 'scum' unless paid.

Which gave Izuku the perfect out.

Right as Katsuki caught up to him, they looked at each other.

Time slowed for Izuku as their determined glares clashed as intense as lightning.

He could see the reflection of himself in Katsuki's helmet's visor. His eyes were overlaid with Katsuki's. As Izuku caught this visual, mixed emotions zapped him like a lightning bolt. Then Katsuki began to reach for his gun.

Izuku abruptly stopped running.

Katsuki's head whipped backwards as Izuku juked in an entirely different direction.

Izuku took off towards the night market. He knew it would be at its peak density this time of night. He heard Katsuki's motorcycle come to a violent, skidding halt. The pounding sound of running footsteps began to chase behind him.

Right as Izuku reached the entrance of the night market, he could see Katsuki behind him again. This time Katsuki was wielding his knife. He was fiercely gritting his teeth as he chased after him.

Izuku didn't slow down as he came in contact with the crowd. He said quick apologies as he began shoving people out of his way.

A litany of obscenities and screaming erupted as the two of them whirled through the crowd like a storm. People began parting like the red sea for their typhoon. Even the wind felt like it picked up with them, rattling the red lanterns above.

Everything began twisting in a blur of craziness. Crowds were yelling. Shop owners were grabbing their goods. Families were clutching their children. The white and red lights were nearly blinding as Izuku ran from his husband.

Izuku looked to the side as saw an upcoming merchant booth. It was selling fancy, decorative parasols. Izuku extended out his hand to grab one as he ran. Immediately the store owner screamed at him—but then she gasped when she saw Katsuki barreling through with a knife.

Izuku twirled on his feet and swung the parasol as if it was a blade.

Katsuki ducked and dodged swiftly. They began to maneuver around each other like trained aerobatic dancers. Izuku tried his best to get jabs in. He hit Katsuki's neck. His side. Then he slapped him upside the head with the hard item. He tried to hit him as hard as possible, but it was like Katsuki was made of stone.

For every jab Izuku was able to land, Katsuki blocked two more. He was quicker than he was at the masquerade and the determined fury in his eyes was stronger. Katsuki started matching Izuku's skilled footing and they began an exchange of back-and-forth hits and dodges.

Izuku began to stagger as Katsuki started to gain on him. He was swinging the knife in a way Izuku never saw him do, and with every attack, he slashed away at the flimsy parasol, wearing it down.

When the parasol seemed like it was about to break, Izuku cursed under his breath. He tried to turn and run.

But right as he tried to flee, his duffle bag was grasped in that iron hold.

Izuku yelped as he was brutally yanked backwards. He nearly fell but balanced on his heels. He tried to grab his bag back, but Katsuki was always stronger. Izuku used all his agility to whirl and in the same motion hit Katsuki's head over and over with the parasol.

It was here that Katsuki began to try to slash at Izuku's neck with his other hand. Izuku blocked all of the attempts like he was a delicate ballet dancer, light on his toes. They went around and around like they were forever caught in a dizzying circle.

Katsuki tried once more to go for the kill. He shot his hand with the knife forward.

Izuku acted on reflexes. He bent backwards and opened the parasol. Katsuki's fist and knife broke through the paper material. The point of the blade stopped less than an inch away from Izuku's face.

Izuku closed the parasol on Katsuki's arm and trapped it inside. He twisted in a swift motion, making Katsuki's arm bend unnaturally. Katsuki hissed as he tried to roll with the gesture. He was forced to let go of the duffle bag so he could follow the movement without breaking a bone.

But Izuku then tripped him up.

Katsuki lost balance and Izuku used the momentum to throw Katsuki. With a loud yell, he tossed Katsuki across the way into another merchant stand that was full of touristy clothes.

Katsuki's large body came crashing down on the wooden stand like he was a boulder.

Scandalized gasps breached both of their ears as Katsuki's heavy body broke the stand into pieces. Shelves began toppling down. Wooden planks clattered to the ground. In a dramatic fashion, endless skirts, shirts, and sakura flower print pants piled onto Katsuki like falling leaves.

Izuku didn't wait to see if that slowed Katsuki or not.

He took off running through the rest of the night market. Behind him he heard Katsuki scream his name with so much sheer anger it felt like the cry rattled the sky.

When Izuku broke free of the crowd, so many unwelcoming eyes were on him. Izuku looked for the port area and began running towards the boats.

He heard the impossible sound of heavy footsteps behind him and glanced over his shoulder.

Katsuki was gaining on him like a twister at full speed. He was throwing clothes off of him as he headed right in his direction. He tried to catch up, but Izuku was always faster.

Izuku sped around the corner straight for the docks. He saw most of the boats were gone now, and there was no time to hot wire a speed boat. Izuku's heart pounded faster and faster as his feet began to burn from exhaustion.

He pushed himself harder. Quicker. He groaned through the strain on his muscles.

Right when he thought he was out of options, he saw one boat that was leaving the pier.

A rope dangled off the back.

Izuku breathed in deep for oxygen as he gave himself one last push. Several more bullets whizzed by him, skinning his neck and legs. Izuku flinched but didn't waver. He leaned forward and briskly ran straight for the boat that was setting sail. He barreled down the dock and the wooden surface was creaking underneath the enormous force of his speed.

Katsuki was right behind him and Izuku could hear him try to speed up.

When Izuku came to the edge of the pier, he leapt.

Izuku reached his hands forward with all his will as he grabbed a hold of the swinging rope. It dropped with his weight before catching. He swung, then slammed into the hard surface of the boat with a loud thud. The taste of iron filled his mouth.

The burn on his palms tore through him as he began desperately climbing. Bullets sunk into the metal surface all around him and into his duffle bag. He gritted his teeth as he tried to pull himself to safety. He reached the top and was able to grab ahold of the railing and pull himself over.

Right as his body was about to drop to the deck, he screamed out in agony. A bullet sliced right through his bicep.

Izuku's body hit the wooden deck ungracefully. He clutched his arm in pain. He hissed as his muscles began to violently convulse.

But Izuku kept himself low to the surface and curled up. He looked up fearfully, hoping no one else was around. Much to his relief, luck was on his side.

The deck was empty. Plus, from the looks of it, it was a single fisherman's boat. Coupled with the overwhelming smell of raw fish, there were piles of nets, rods and crates placed off to the side and stacked like building blocks.

Then Izuku heard footsteps. Someone began to hastily run towards him.

Izuku desperately crawled over to the side of the deck full of wooden crates and tarps. He hid himself underneath one tarp that was lazily draped over a pile of crates. He crawled under it all the way and made no noise.

Through a slim crack, Izuku could see one singular fisherman come racing to the deck. The man whirled around with wide eyes, entirely alarmed. He gripped his wiry hair in confusion and paused however when he found nothing.

The fisherman squinted his eyes out to the pier and then stood there for a moment. Then two. Then as if he gaslit himself out of what he heard, the fisherman scratched his head.

The man turned around and Izuku nearly sighed in relief. He walked back to the front of the boat and continued to steer.

Izuku waited a minute. He tried his best to catch his breath, but it was like oxygen was avoiding him. His lungs were hurting as if someone set them on fire and filled them with smoke. Izuku leaned against a crate and clutched his arm tightly to slow the bleeding.

After a moment, Izuku peaked carefully from underneath the tarp. He briefly looked over the edge of the boat.

Standing on another end of the dock was Katsuki. He was calm like a quiet storm that knew its strengths to topple entire villages. He seemed so sure and stoic in his endless pit of hate standing there.

Katsuki's eyes then found him.

For a brief moment, they locked distant gazes.

Izuku's broken heart clutched with pain. The bitter, winter wind blew between them.

The soft sound of distant sound of police sirens began to head towards the pier.

He watched as Katsuki pulled his hood over his head. He didn't break their eye contact until he finally turned around. Katsuki began to walk quickly away from the scene. He disappeared into the mayhem of the night right as the blue and red lights approached.

Izuku's stomach sank to the lowest pits it'd ever been in.



Izuku jolted awake when the boat jerked to a hard stop.

The first thing that assaulted his senses was the smell of fish. It was potent and smothered everywhere, reminding him that he was on a Fisherman's boat. Following that he heard a cluster of voices down by the front. The people come towards the back and begin to gather items from the deck.

Izuku stayed as still as possible under the tarp as people began to work around him.

The fisherman spoke to someone, then as quickly as they came, all the voices were gone.

Izuku waited until the count of one hundred to move. He peaked from underneath the tarp to make sure he was alone and was relieved to find he was. There was no one else but him and the cold, howling wind.

Izuku stood up slowly on his wobbly legs. He groaned softly as all the muscles in his body protested loudly. His legs felt like they were ready to fall off at any given moment and Izuku nearly wanted that.

Izuku finally pulled his hand away from clutching his arm.

Bright red blood coated the entirety of his palm. He looked down to see a large blood stain soaked through his new winter jacket.

Izuku got off the boat and immediately used the dingy water in the bay to clean his hand.

He watched as the blood washed away like ink diffusing. As he studied the shapes the blood created in the water, he didn't want to think too much about it. He was terrified that if he closely examined his emotions now, his body might shut down into paralyzed fear.

Instead, he refocused. He needed to find a way to Midnight Sento *immediately*. As he did this he tried his best to ignore the trembles that were working their way through his fingers. He scanned the area, curious to where he was. It was still night outside, so they couldn't have gone far.

He got his answer when he turned his head fully and saw a wooden sign.

In white lettering it said, "Welcome to Sumoto, Hyogo."

Izuku hung his head in relief.

He was slightly closer to where he needed to go, but not terribly far from where he was at. Sumoto was located on Awaji Island which lay directly on the other side of the Osaka Bay. Which meant Izuku only needed to get back to the mainland and keep heading south.

As Izuku stood up, he instantly became light-headed. He staggered, nearly falling over right there on the pier. Izuku choked when spots danced across his vision and nausea landed in his stomach.

The fatigue officially caught up with him. Izuku closed his eyes until the spell passed. When he felt slightly better, he decided that he needed to rest for an hour or two. If he wanted to make it to Shinonsen without passing out, he needed to regain a bit of his strength that he just depleted from outrunning Katsuki.

As Izuku began to walk into town, he was reeling on the fact that Katsuki really did find him.

Izuku didn't know what he felt more: fear or genuinely impressed.

He decided it was fear. Katsuki possessed terrifyingly advanced tracking abilities that Izuku never was aware of. And because of that, he likely would not be able to spend too long anywhere.

Izuku hoped the boat getaway was ambiguous enough to throw Katsuki off his scent for a couple of days. Even Izuku didn't know where the boat was heading, and that fact alone meant neither did Katsuki. As far as Katsuki knew, Izuku was halfway north by now.

Izuku hoped that would be sufficient enough for him to get the hell out of reach.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When Izuku wandered into the small city, it was decently sized.

There was a large hotel for tourists and civilians in the more populated area. Many of the shops and buildings however were closed this time of night.

Izuku looked at the main hotel and decided against it. He walked a bit further and made a long trek to the outskirts of the city for extra measure.

He found the smallest, most discrete motel he could. It was a bit shabby, and Izuku could tell it hadn't been taken care of in a long time. The sign flickered on and off and there were no cars in the parking lot. It likely had less than three stars on its reviews, which made it perfect for laying low.

Izuku walked into the motel door, and the bell chimed like a melody as he walked in. The first thing he was greeted with was the smell of old dust. The next was a lingering smell of nicotine. The smell was a bit moldy, as if moisture was embedded behind the faded floral wallpaper.

The man sitting at the check-in desk didn't even see him at first.

His large eyes were glued to his laptop and in his ears were a pair of wired headphones blasting noise. Whatever he was watching must have been intense because he adjusted his round glasses and leaned in to get a closer look.

As Izuku approached he noticed the man's oily comb over, and a slightly uncombed gray mustache.

Izuku politely stood there and then cleared his throat.

The man startled with a light gasp. He perked up, seemingly surprised to see Izuku. Then he quickly slammed his laptop shut and snatched out his ear buds. He stared at Izuku for a moment, as if confused as to why he would be here, of all places.

Izuku gave a stiff smile.

"May I have a room for the night, please?" Izuku asked.

“O-Oh yes! Of course,” The clerk replied. He was slightly antsy. “Give me just one moment!”

He cleared his messy space as he reached for the drawer next to him. When he pulled it open, Izuku saw a cluster of silver and gold keys slide around. Some were marked with green tape, others with red. Izuku furrowed his brow at how disorganized this all was.

“Do you have a preference for what kind of room?” The clerk asked while adjusting his glasses. “One bed or two?” He then sniffed the air a bit and leaned back. He wrinkled his nose and gazed at Izuku curiously. He scanned him up and down and finally saw the blood on his coat. “A room with a working shower, perhaps?”

Izuku blinked. He lightly sniffed himself. He flinched at the rancid smell of fish clinging to him. It only took a few seconds for his neck to burn from embarrassment. The stench from the fisherman’s boat must’ve rubbed off on him.

“One bed with a working shower would be nice,” Izuku answered quietly.

He silently wondered why a working shower wouldn’t be a part of the deal in the first place.

“Okay,” the clerk replied. He pulled out a silver key with a green piece of tape. “Here you go! Please remember to check out and return the key before you leave. Don’t make a mess!”

“Of course.”

Izuku took the key and gave the money for the night in exchange.

As he walked away, the clerk carefully opened his laptop once more and put his headphones in.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku walked the outside halls of the motel to his room.

It was emptier than a haunted house and quiet enough to hear a pin drop. He curiously peered inside the windows of the other rooms but found no lights on. He frowned deeply when a roach scurried from underneath the crack of one door.

When he reached his room, it somehow felt sketchier than the rest of the motel.

There was one bed and half of a washroom. There was no window in the bathroom and the only way in or out of the room was the door.

The linen on top of the bed was a spotted gray and yellow color, like it was once supposed to be white and turned colors from dust and questionable spills. There was a mirror on the wall that was slightly crooked and what felt like stock photos of roses were pinned on the wallpaper that was peeling towards the top.

The first thing Izuku did was close the blinds. The curtains themselves were also half done really. They were a single shear layer of material that barely blocked any light. Izuku made a note not to linger by the window too much and to get out of this place as soon as possible.

Izuku sighed and dropped his duffle bag onto the bed.

He turned on the light in the room, but the bulb flickered once and cut off. Of *course*. Just his luck.

Slightly irritated, Izuku stalked over to the small lamp that was on the wooden nightstand. When he twisted the knob, the lamp flickered a bit, but then found its power to stay on.

The tiny yellow light only filled half of the space. Izuku moved to check the drawers or the nightstand. At the bottom most drawer he found old, discarded items stashed inside. There was a crusted bottle of lotion, three sticks of gum, four cigarettes, half a used bottle of lube, and a lighter all tucked inside.

Izuku scrunched his nose.

He picked up the lighter, thought it might be useful, and tossed it onto the bed halfheartedly.

As he slammed the drawer closed, his body ached to be laid down. He felt the ache in his arm begin to demand attention and Izuku's legs were burning from too much use. Izuku tiredly unzipped his coat and began to strip down.

He lazily kicked his garments to the side of the bed and walked into the washroom.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku sat on the edge of the bed with a towel wrapped around his waist.

He applied pressure to his arm's bullet wound with a paper towel that was doused with disinfectant. As he did this, he kept his eyes peeled on the TV that played in the background.

He listened to the news to keep a watchful ear out for any stories that felt tinted in Yakuza or Viper like venom. Surprisingly, it seemed calm. There were no other updates about the fire in Tokyo and nothing else seemed to be happening. Which made Izuku a bit nervous.

He guessed both the Vipers and Yakuza were calculating their next move. Or maybe they had other priorities besides Izuku. Which Izuku slightly doubted for the Vipers. Tomura's only business sometimes was wrangling him like a true caretaker. His brother was definitely coming up with some plan to drag him back home.

The only news story that he saw that was cause for alarm was the one about 'Mayhem at the Osaka Night Market'.

There, like a pulsing sore thumb, were reports of the chase between him and Katsuki. All the footage was luckily blurry and it was far too dark for either of their faces to be caught. They were moving much too fast for people to get a good identifiable shot of them.

Instead, they looked like two blurs of green and red clashing like great waves.

They always were a storm together, weren't they? Izuku thought solemnly.

He watched the clips replay over and over until they finally disappeared. The news moved on to talking about something else entirely, and Izuku couldn't bear to pay it any mind. Unfortunately, his thoughts stayed fixed on Katsuki.

He pulled the paper towel away from his arm.

He took the moment to study the blood splotches soaked into the towel.

His wound stopped bleeding for the most part. The bullet cut clean through him, leaving no fragments. He was beyond lucky this bullet didn't shatter his bone or sever a major artery. Exactly like the other two times Katsuki shot him.

A tug in his stomach made him pause.

It was here that a peculiar thought crossed Izuku's mind.

For most of his life, he always assumed Katsuki had bad aim. All the years he and Katsuki took turns in shooting each other, they never landed a lethal one. Izuku knew why *he* couldn't; he had a mental block. But he always simply assumed Katsuki was poorly trained and that's why he never landed one.

However, after seeing Katsuki at the peak of his capabilities twice now, Izuku was beginning to wonder: did Katsuki really have as bad of aim as he thought?

Katsuki cleared out Moore's headquarters without harming any of the victims. And less than three days ago, he killed about fifty Yakuza without much effort.

Someone with bad aim wouldn't have been able to accomplish either of those things.

Izuku's thumb slid across the blood on the cloth in a slow caress.

He turned to look at his duffle bag beside him. It had several holes in it from where Katsuki's bullets cut through it, and even some light slashes. However, all these were indicative of the bad aim that Izuku was unsure Katsuki really possessed.

He inspected the bag out of curiosity. He pulled out a couple of the bullets that were lodged in the thick material of the bag. He couldn't stop himself from running his finger across one of the slashes. Izuku turned the bag over to see if there were any more bullets caught inside of it.

However, his heart stopped when he saw something that was definitely *not* a bullet.

On the belly of the bag was a small black chip.

It was identical to the one Katsuki put on the car.

Izuku stood straight up and snatched the chip off. The tiny metal teeth tore from the material of the bag and pricked his finger when he clutched it. He held it up to his wide eyes.

“You’re *kidding* me,” Izuku loudly exasperated.

It was blinking and it was *working*.

Izuku immediately crushed it against the wall into tiny pieces.

He stared in disbelief as the fragments fell to the ground. It clicked then that Katsuki must’ve stuck it on him while he grabbed his bag in the marketplace. In their tussle, Izuku hadn’t even realized it. Of course. That’s why Katsuki was so calm on the dock. Katsuki was far more thorough than Izuku ever thought.

He turned around frantically, glancing over his shoulder at the window.

Without a moment’s hesitation, Izuku began re-packing. He turned off the TV, killed all the lights and began shoving all his guns and clothes back into the duffle bag.

He quickly rotated his bag, eyes scanning all over. He carefully made sure that there were not any more trackers on it. Next he did the same to his coat and his pants. He found no more chips, but somehow that gave him less hope. Katsuki probably had more just *waiting* to tag on him.

His gut was actively twisting into several knots like it was a balloon animal being toyed with for amusement. He could feel the hands contorting his insides to belong to Katsuki’s. It was only a matter of time before that became true.

Izuku threw on the first pair of clothes he could put on and snatched his coat. He pulled out a single handgun, cocked it, and held it tightly in his hand.

He hastily put on his shoes, nearly tripping in the progress. He didn’t bother to tie them as he ran for the door with his duffle bag clutched in his hand.

But he froze in his tracks when a tall, looming shadow passed by the window.

Izuku looked up like a trapped animal. His heart skipped when he recognized the silhouette.

It was Katsuki with his wild hair and broad shoulders.

There was nowhere to run, and Izuku’s legs were shaking, begging to be given rest. He ducked behind the door as the shadow stopped. Izuku watched as the shadow paused and peered in.

Izuku melted into the corner and held his breath.

Katsuki shifted on his feet. Izuku paid close attention as Katsuki’s heavy footsteps suddenly shifted to sound like he was walking on clouds. Izuku silently noted how well Katsuki did that. He was really good at stealthiness when he wanted to be.

Izuku was grasping how all these years he had never truly been at the blunt end of Katsuki's lethality—until now.

The door began to rattle.

Izuku's eyes cut down to the shaking doorknob. Katsuki was picking the lock.

Izuku's heart palpitated. He quickly looked towards the other side of the room and began to quietly crawl on all fours with haste. Izuku swiftly maneuvered himself and his bag under the bed, completely swallowed by the darkness.

He put his finger on his gun's trigger, right as the door clicked open.

Katsuki's black combat boots came into view.

Katsuki stood there for a moment, scanning the dark room and then gradually he closed the door behind him. He quietly locked the door.

Izuku watched as his husband's feet carefully stepped around the room. Izuku could barely hear his footsteps.

Katsuki came near the bed and Izuku held his breath. Several intense heart beats quaked through him and then finally Katsuki passed the bed. Katsuki checked the closet, behind the dresser, and even under the desk. This was all done with eerie silence like he was made of air.

Next, Katsuki stalked over into the back towards the washroom.

Izuku gazed at the door that was now left unguarded with desperation.

It was only a matter of time before Katsuki checked under the bed.

Very slowly, Izuku began sliding against the carpeted floor on his arms. He was virtually soundless as he glided. He hauled his bag with him, and right as he made it halfway from under the bed, he suddenly was stopped by a terrifying force.

Two large hands wrapped around his ankles and yanked.

Izuku's heart sank straight down into his twisted gut.

Izuku gritted his teeth as he was pulled backwards with unprecedented strength. He tried to fight against it, but Katsuki was always stronger. He immediately twisted his body when he was pulled all the way to the other side. He aimed his gun directly at Katsuki's arm within point blank range. Katsuki tried to dodge, but Izuku was always faster.

Izuku pulled the trigger. Blood splattered across the wall and Katsuki screamed.

Izuku steeled his nerves at that specific sound because he hated Katsuki in *pain*—

Izuku tried to aim for knocking Katsuki out again. If he could do that, he could escape. Or he could tie Katsuki up and they finally sit down and talk *properly*.

He took his gun and swung with all his strength to hit Katsuki in his temple, but Katsuki countered.

He grabbed Izuku's wrist as if he knew he was going to do it. Katsuki gritted his teeth through the bleeding and twisted Izuku's hands backwards at a grotesque angle.

Izuku yelled in pain as he was forced to drop his gun. He quickly threw his body weight up and caught Katsuki in a headlock with his legs. He squeezed his thighs together until he felt Katsuki choke.

Katsuki let go of his wrists. He tried to pry Izuku's legs off. His fingernails dug into Izuku's muscular quads with terrifying force—but Izuku locked him in. Katsuki pulled frantically as Izuku's grip grew stronger and then he abruptly stood up.

Izuku hissed as he was lifted upwards at a disorienting speed. His whole world was tossed into an upside-down blur as Katsuki began to spin around. Izuku hoisted himself upright in the cyclone they were now caught in. He grabbed a hold of Katsuki's head and forced him further into his suffocating head lock.

As Katsuki tried his best to shake him off, Izuku wouldn't let go—no matter how much his legs were trembling. Katsuki then slammed them into wall after wall with brutal velocity. They shook the dresser, bed, mirror, and all the pictures on the walls.

Katsuki's fingernails scraped away at Izuku's thighs. But Izuku gritted his teeth through the pain and kept Katsuki locked in his confining hold.

Izuku began to grab ahold of Katsuki's hair and pushed him in further to his leg lock. He then repeatedly dropped the point of his elbow down on Katsuki's head in a frantic pursuit to knock him out cold.

It was here that Katsuki's attempts to shake him off grew more frenzied. He sunk his fingers into Izuku's hips and gripped tight. With bewildering speed, he threw both of them into the mirror latched to the wall.

The glass shattered and it sliced through the air. Izuku covered his face instinctively. He choked out as the glass broke against his head, legs, and arms. He lost his leg lock grip slightly. Immediately, Katsuki used the small opening and wrenched Izuku off. Izuku grunted as he was thrown down to the ground.

As he fell, he grabbed onto Katsuki and together they went tumbling down.

Both of their heads hit the floor with a hard thud. Both of them gasped for air.

They dizzyingly glared at each other, ready to make another hasty move but Izuku struck first.

Through his double vision he kicked at Katsuki, hoping he hit the right one. He did. Katsuki was knocked to the side as Izuku's foot connected with his face. Izuku tried his best to scramble upright in the glassy mess beneath them.

Then Katsuki tackled him. They went flying together into the nightstand and Izuku slammed his elbow back. He hit Katsuki in the neck. Katsuki choked. Izuku whirled around. He grabbed the lamp and smashed it against Katsuki with all the strength he had left. Katsuki hissed and fell. Izuku tried to run but was dragged down.

They dropped down together and began an all too familiar push and pull.

Izuku's blistering anxiety began creeping up.

He tried to fight against Katsuki. But it was the equivalent of struggling to keep his head above water in an unruly ocean storm. There was no raft. No safety. No one came to save him. Every time he thought he broke through the surface, he was hauled back down underneath and nearly drowned.

Izuku grappled for the bed to hoist himself up. Instantly, Katsuki's hand eclipsed his and dragged him down. The sheets came down with his failed attempt this time. The gray linen poured over them and Izuku wrestled it into wrapping around Katsuki's head. He pinned down Katsuki in a mess of tangles and was finally free.

Then there was a swift drag of a knife, cutting straight through the sheets.

Izuku tried to run for the door.

But he was stopped when Katsuki stabbed his knife through his pants' leg. Izuku was pinned in place, and he fell down at the sudden pull. The side of his body hit the floor with a loud bang. He looked up. He was mere inches from the door. Katsuki began to drag him back. Izuku kicked and yelled as he tried to crawl his way to freedom.

But Katsuki was always stronger.

Izuku was dragged away from the door.

They struggled against each other, and Katsuki began winning. Izuku tried to push him off to no avail.

Soon he found himself pinned underneath Katsuki, back to the ground. Katsuki forced his way between his legs and used all his body weight to forcefully keep Izuku in place. His hands struggled their way around Izuku's neck and *squeezed*.

Izuku gasped, eyes wide when the air was cut off from his lungs.

He tried to scratch Katsuki's hands off, but it was pointless.

He knew this chokehold. This was the first chokehold Katsuki ever put him in. It held no care. No tenderness and not an ounce of softness. They had come full circle. Deep down,

Izuku always knew that Katsuki's hands were destined to be forever wrapped around his throat, either in love or with murderous intent.

And it looked like in the end, it was the latter.

Izuku gazed up at Katsuki.

He found himself met with what was possibly the end of his life: red eyes and blond hair.

Everything suspended in time as he stared into those eyes. They pulled him in like always, forever his one true weakness up until the bitter end. As he sank to the bottom of the sea of scarlet, Izuku saw all the versions of Katsuki come to life in front of him.

They flashed before his eyes in reverse.

He saw this vengeful, steadfast Katsuki. Then he saw the broken-hearted Katsuki. Next he saw the Katsuki who said he loved him at his family's grave site. And then the Katsuki who called him darling so sweetly. The Katsuki who showed him who he was when he wasn't a Viper.

The Katsuki who drunkenly recited vows. The Katsuki who smiled at him for the first time. The Katsuki who teased him. The grumpy Katsuki who reluctantly held his hand. The Katsuki who helped him escape danger. The Katsuki who gave him his shirt. The Katsuki in Taiwan. The Katsuki in Vienna.

Then finally, he saw young Kacchan.

He remembered how he wandered into Izuku's life in the cold. He was shivering, no coat and crying for his mother.

He stared at present Katsuki in front of him, who was still grieving for his mother.

Izuku stopped struggling.

The air was leaving him quickly. But as Izuku lost himself to Katsuki, he was unable to keep fighting his ultimate weakness.

Once he began feeling lightheaded, a sad piece of him decided that this was okay. There was a bittersweet level of comfort in knowing this would be the end of his life. At least he would be put out of his misery doing the thing he loved to do most: staring into lovely red eyes.

Tears slipped out of Izuku.

Katsuki's expression faltered. He blinked rapidly a bit. Then quickly reverted back to his anger. He pushed forward in his resolve.

Izuku memorized this last version of Katsuki's eyes.

They were full of fury, blazing hot. The constricted pupil in the middle was like a burning coal simmering angrily in the ocean of scarlet. The bloodshot veins encircled the irises,

stretching across the planes of white like broken glass. The veiny tendrils spread all over, making Katsuki's eyes appear like they were nothing but deep, endless red.

Izuku thought it was lovely.

As spots danced across his vision, his arms went limp and dropped to his sides. His head lulled and he blinked in long lags as his vision lost focus.

Izuku blinked once. Then twice. Then the third time he blinked, the eyes burning down on him wavered in their fury.

Katsuki stared down at Izuku and confusion struck him. A different emotion gradually fought its way up. Katsuki's eyes went wide, and his hands around Izuku's neck began to shake.

Black spilled into the sides of Izuku's vision.

He blinked once more, and Katsuki's pupils were no longer constricted. His pupils dilated all the way his hands around Izuku's neck loosened entirely.

Air slammed into Izuku's lungs like a baseball bat to the chest.

Izuku began coughing violently. He grabbed instinctively at his throat as the wind swept its way through him. His hands landed on top of Katsuki's, which were still resting around his neck.

He frantically blinked and suddenly he was being showered in hot tears. They dripped down one by one like rain droplets. Izuku's blurry vision focused to reveal Katsuki crying.

Katsuki was fighting a war.

He was gritting his teeth in anger, but his eyes were glossy with despair. Katsuki quickly wiped his face, as though he was frustrated with himself. He got rid of his tears before they could change his mind and he reached for his knife.

Izuku closed his eyes when he saw the blade come in view. He willingly craned his neck and screwed his eyes shut—but the blade stopped directly as it touched his Adam's apple. Izuku kept his eyes tightly screwed closed as he waited for his throat to be slit open.

But it never came.

He hesitantly opened his eyes again.

Katsuki's hands were shaking, and his tears were pouring faster. Katsuki's nostrils flared and it seemed like he was trying to force himself to do it. His eyes were darting all around Izuku's face. He searched Izuku's features as if the answer on how to take the kill would be written in Izuku's freckles.

Izuku sadly took Katsuki's shaking hand. He steadied the blade.

“It’s yours to take, Kacchan,” Izuku whispered past his quivering lips. “It’s okay. It’s always been yours anyways.”

Izuku tried to help guide Katsuki’s hand to slit his throat, but Katsuki’s hand didn’t budge. He was met with extreme resistance as Katsuki remained paralyzed in place. Gradually, Katsuki’s whole body shook more violently and then firmly clenched his jaw.

Then, he exploded.

It erupted at once as Katsuki screamed out a loud, frustrated curse. He snatched the knife far away from Izuku’s throat and his body rocked forward.

Izuku didn’t flinch as the knife was lodged into the floor next to his ear.

He stared wide eyed in shock at Katsuki who was staring right back with the same emotion. Tears steadily fell down on him over and over. Soon, they mixed in with his own.

“I—I *can’t*.” Katsuki’s voice broke in the most heartbreaking way. “I *c-can’t* do it.”

Katsuki’s face twisted and contorted with disbelief. He clutched the handle of his blade fiercely. His trembling fingers grasped tightly over the area where his mother’s name was etched.

His eyes were torn between love and hate. Guilt and rage. He struggled back and forth trying to decide which emotion would ultimately win. Then the victor finally showed itself: it was none other than sadness, draped in the years of grief Katsuki had never processed.

Katsuki’s face crumbled along with all his terrifying armor. All his walls of anger came crashing down as his body trembled like an earthquake. Katsuki screwed his eyes shut and turned his head shamefully away from Izuku. He choked out several, muffled cries as he bit his lip.

Then Katsuki hunched over Izuku, weeping. He rested their foreheads together.

All the anger inside of him boiled down. It evaporated into the air to reveal grief and mourning sitting heavy at the bottom of his body. It was dragging him down and he couldn’t lift his limbs.

Katsuki lowered his head into the crook of Izuku’s neck and his free hand threaded through Izuku’s hair softly.

“Wh-Why can’t I d-do it?” Katsuki cried as he clutched the handle of his blade tighter.

They both wondered why at that moment. It should’ve been so clear cut to kill the other. They both had plenty of opportunities, but they never did all these years. Because while Izuku was always faster and Katsuki was always stronger, they both were always weak for the other.

Izuku wrapped his shaking arms around Katsuki’s trembling body.

Izuku pulled him in close for an embrace, and Katsuki accepted it. Izuku held Katsuki as they both cried. He was unsure of what was going to happen after this. But all he knew right now was that he needed to comfort Katsuki for this single fleeting moment.

Then Katsuki's head shifted up. Their noses brushed from the close proximity. They looked at each other, eyes locked.

A split second of silence.

There was a primal pull at the base of Izuku's core. It was stronger than two magnets near each other, surged with the need to connect. As they held eye contact, all their high-strung emotions fused and snapped them together.

Izuku let out a shaky, unsteady breath. Katsuki's hand in his hair gripped tighter. Izuku's fingers dug into Katsuki's shoulders. Their breaths quickened together. Then they both closed their eyes right as Katsuki lowered his head and Izuku tilted his head up.

They locked into a ferocious kiss and together they tipped right over the deep end.

Chapter End Notes

(「•-•)「 *pops bottle of champagne while I lock my doors* 🍾

Thank you all so much for reading!! Let me know what you think below— 💜💜💜

Chapter 30: Fortepiano

Chapter Summary

> Fortepiano (Volume) — To play loudly then immediately play softly.
>
> Izuku and Katsuki have it out.

Chapter Notes

> Hellooo!! Welcome back to this choochoo train of angst :) This is a long awaited chapter! First, big thank you to LOML, Luna for betaing like always! She's a powerhouse 💜 Secondly, thank you all so much for your comments 🥹❤️ everyone is so kind! You're all awesome!
>
> Without further wait, here is the chapter :)
>
> **Warnings: That looming "Knife Play" tag thats been sitting there forever finally comes into action in this chapter**

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 30 — Fortepiano

.

.

.

As they pulled each other impossibly closer, Izuku's lightheaded mind flooded with mixed emotions.

Katsuki kissing him felt like a fleeting dream after so long. He trembled with the fact that Katsuki couldn't kill him. After all this time, he was just like Izuku. This groundbreaking fact reinforced all his beliefs about Katsuki. It made him press deeper into the kiss and his lucidity was buried under all the heavy emotions he was feeling.

His credulous heart seized the moment, not listening to his logic as they melted together.

The salty taste of their tears mixed in with the kiss as they plunged further into oblivion. Push and pull. Grab and clutch. They feverishly latched together like they needed the other more

than air.

He had never experienced a kiss like this with Katsuki. They shared passionate kisses, soft kisses, even shy ones. But this kiss was staggeringly different. It was rough like nails and Izuku could taste the desperation sitting on the edge of both of their tongues.

When Katsuki grabbed his neck, warmth surged from the tip of Izuku's fingers all the way down towards his toes.

The growing heat mixed in with all his heightened emotions. His adrenaline became craving. His desperation twisted into want. And his terror transformed into exhilaration. It all swirled together into one final thought: he needed Katsuki. *Now*.

Izuku began grinding up on him. In response, Katsuki began harshly grinding down.

A breathy gasp was pushed out of Izuku's lips and into Katsuki's mouth. Katsuki did it again and again, pulling more breathless moans out of Izuku that he swallowed eagerly. Soon, this rhythmic movement became desperate rutting that was making Izuku flat out moan.

Tingles of pleasure began igniting like flames all over his skin. Izuku needed more. He wrapped his arms and legs around Katsuki, locking him in as they rocked. Then Katsuki gripped the nape of Izuku's hair in a tight hold and began rubbing their growing erections together fiercely.

Heat sparked awake like a fire being quickly fanned. Izuku gave a heady, light gasp as they began to frot frantically. He whined as his cock pulsed with waves of addictive pleasure and grew to a full hard-on.

The lingering fear began to hold hands with his pleasure. Together, his nerves spiked to new highs as he willingly offered himself up to Katsuki.

They broke apart for air only for a moment. The next second they were back to drowning the other.

Katsuki forcefully tilted Izuku's head and deepened the kiss. Izuku eagerly opened his mouth and allowed their tongues to slide against each other. They began moving their clothed erections together sensually, with purpose.

It was maddening. Izuku needed Katsuki closer. Katsuki needed to destroy Izuku. Both of their bodies ached to be buried in rapture. Izuku began rocking his hips upwards like an animal in heat, whimpering as they dry humped recklessly.

Katsuki pulled away from the kiss with Izuku's bottom lip caught between his teeth. Izuku hissed as Katsuki bit down, drawing a bit of blood. He sat up with Katsuki as Katsuki pulled *hard*. The pain trickled in, and with it a new type of euphoria. It pulsed in tiny hot white flashes as Katsuki kept his flesh between his teeth.

Katsuki let go of his lip and a tiny bit of Izuku's blood was coated on his mouth. He wiped it off his lips with the back of his hand. Izuku licked the blood up from his bottom lip, coating

his palate in the taste of iron.

Katsuki's eyes darkened as Izuku's tongue darted out slowly.

After that, Katsuki began working quickly. He shrugged off his jacket and snatched off his shirt. The bullet wound from where Izuku had shot him was smeared with blood, but Katsuki moved as if he didn't feel it. He undid his pants' button and Izuku began to undress as well.

Izuku flung off his jacket like it was burning him. But when he made a move to remove his shirt, Katsuki's hand shot out.

Suddenly the point of Katsuki's knife was at the base of his chin.

Izuku froze and his breath hitched.

The sharp end of the blade nicked him a bit. Izuku carefully assessed Katsuki as an unexpected rush poured into him.

His vicious husband was inspecting him like he was prey.

Frightening red eyes began to roam his body and Izuku shuddered under the gaze. It felt like Katsuki's stare alone was burning right through his clothes. Katsuki then homed in on Izuku's bulging erection. He applied pressure to his knife a bit, and Izuku exhaled heavily through his nose.

His cock visibly jumped.

A cruel scoff erupted from Katsuki.

Deliberately, Katsuki leaned in until they nearly kissed. But they didn't. He stopped mere inches from Izuku's bleeding lip.

Katsuki's mouth twitched into an unkind smirk.

Izuku gasped as he was suddenly slammed backwards. Katsuki pinned him down to the ground again without any gentleness. Izuku barely saw the speed Katsuki worked with. Soon his husband had trapped both his wrists above his head with a single hand.

Izuku's heart skipped a beat when he looked up.

Katsuki looked as mean as could be.

Izuku's heart hammered as his ears thundered with his pulse. He squirmed as he became unexpectedly turned on further.

Katsuki tightened the grip on his wrists and moved to pull something out of his pants' pockets. Something small, translucent, and shiny came into view. When Izuku saw what it was, he held his breath. It was a zip tie.

Katsuki forcefully dragged him across the floor towards the bed.

He pinned Izuku down to the ground as he tied Izuku's hands to the leg of the bed frame.

He pulled the zip tie tight with force, and it cut into Izuku's skin slightly. Izuku's breathing quickened and his hard-on became painful.

He was scared, aroused, and intrigued. He squirmed on his back as his legs began shaking.

Katsuki held the knife up to his throat and then began to kiss him again. Anger as fiery as ten suns combined poured into the kiss. It seared Izuku's spirit as he welcomed it greedily. Katsuki nipped and sucked and Izuku hissed every time Katsuki meanly bit his lip.

Unhurriedly, Katsuki began to work his way down.

He scraped his teeth against Izuku's jaw, leaving the feeling of fire etched into Izuku's skin. He left various, possessive love bites as he kept his blade perched perfectly against Izuku's throat.

He moved his mouth down gradually, and he sucked hard at Izuku's pulse. Several dark hickeys were left in his wake that sent waves of pleasure straight down to Izuku's crotch. Izuku softly moaned as heat began to intensify between his legs and he ached to become undone.

Katsuki's teeth dragged down to Izuku's clavicle. He licked across his collar as if tasting him and Izuku strained against the zip tie at the tantalizing sensation.

He mewled in a way that made him burn with embarrassment but it egged Katsuki on. Katsuki rocked into him and sunk his teeth into his skin. Ripples of pleasure shot up Izuku's spine and his Adam's apple bobbed against the blade.

Izuku's body strung tight as he looked down at Katsuki.

Molten hot red eyes looked back up at him.

Katsuki moved the blade.

He dragged it down Izuku's abdomen at an excruciatingly slow pace. The sharp tip raked against Izuku leaving behind the feeling of an inferno. It teased him. Beckoned to him. Made him feel like his sanity slipped right through his own fingertips.

Katsuki took his time taking him apart as he circled his sensitive nipples with the blade. He followed the curve of Izuku's sides and languidly moved the blade as if he was ghosting out his name across Izuku's belly.

Then he hooked the blade under the end of Izuku's shirt.

Katsuki's eyes tethered to Izuku's.

With unnatural precision, Katsuki sliced Izuku's shirt open right down the middle. It fell open, exposing Izuku's already hardened nipples and heaving chest. The cold air of the room blanketed Izuku's skin and he began to squirm on the floor.

“K-Kacchan,” Izuku gasped as Katsuki latched onto his chest.

He moaned louder than before as Katsuki got to work. Katsuki began to litter his skin with possessive hickeys that matched the ones on his neck. Izuku groaned as Katsuki sucked and licked. He pulled at his flesh as he pressed the flat side of the knife against his abdomen.

It was cold, chilling, and downright terrifying. But Izuku *loved* it. He locked Katsuki in with his legs, urging on the tantalizing feeling. Everything about this was danger embodied—but it was just like Katsuki. Katsuki, Katsuki, *Katsuki*.

He moaned his husband’s name and closed his eyes as he became drunk on the feeling of Katsuki laying down dozens of hickeys. Then suddenly an unexpected pain hit him.

Izuku hissed as Katsuki bit down on his nipple then roughly sucked.

Izuku’s whole back arched off the floor as his legs shook. He harshly gasped as Katsuki kept going, not letting up. Izuku began calling out Katsuki’s name lewdly as Katsuki flicked his tongue and rolled the sensitive nub between his teeth.

Then a staggering cold touch hit the same bud. Izuku choked. His eyes flew open, and he looked down through his hazy vision.

Katsuki trapped Izuku’s sensitive nipple between his tongue and the dull side of the blade.

He lapped at the bud with his tongue and then immediately rubbed the flat side of the cold blade down on it. Izuku quaked. He was needy. Desperate even—feeling like he might explode.

Katsuki’s hungry eyes watched Izuku as he did this, and suddenly the deadly desire spiked between them. Katsuki moved to the other nipple and gave it the same, rough treatment. Izuku groaned from deep in his core as Katsuki swirled his tongue around his bud. Countless sweltering ripples of pleasure echoed down his limbs.

Izuku’s eyes fluttered closed as Katsuki continued to toy with his chest.

He jolted at every sudden movement, and then the blade shifted. It ran down the inside of his thigh and Izuku whimpered. He arched into the motion and spread his legs to welcome it.

Katsuki didn’t stop sucking on Izuku’s perked buds as his knife dropped low. He hooked the blade on the inside of Izuku’s pants’ leg and sliced upwards, just like he had done with the shirt. Izuku held his breath as Katsuki rolled his nipple between his teeth at the same time his clothing was shredded open.

His husband switched buds and pants’ legs. He did the same thing with more vigor. Izuku’s joggers were in pieces as they were cut clean off his body. His legs turned from trembling to outright shaking as the flat side of the blade inched up his muscular thighs.

Izuku’s chest became overwhelmingly sensitive as the knife crawled closer and closer to his boxers.

Then Katsuki pulled back from his chest, a trail of spit from his lip to Izuku's hardened bud following. He toyed with the knife a bit, like he was testing the resistance of Izuku's boxers against the sharp edge.

Izuku's half lidded eyes flickered back and forth between Katsuki and the blade.

Katsuki's mean expression deepened and Izuku's cock grew harder. His erection poked straight through the thin material of his boxers, so obvious now. It strained to be freed, twitching as pre-cum leaked out of him. Katsuki then moved his blade and pressed the flat side of his knife against Izuku's cock and rubbed it sensually.

Izuku softly moaned and spread his legs until he felt his muscles strain.

Katsuki rubbed Izuku's cock with the blade and Izuku felt like he was spiraling into madness.

With a feverish gasp, Izuku's eyes dilated fully as Katsuki cut his boxers off his body. His cock sprung free, and the shredded material fell to the side.

Izuku laid in the heap of his cut up clothes. He wiggled his arms that were above his head and squirmed slightly as his cock twitched more and more.

He was turned on so much it was hurting.

Katsuki's hungry eyes roamed his naked body. His husband then moved to finally take off Izuku's shoes and threw them elsewhere. He hooked his fingers on his own pants and boxers, pulling them down. In a fluid motion, he then undressed himself and his veiny cock hung free right in front of Izuku.

He began stroking himself, letting his pre-cum drip down onto Izuku's cock. Then he spat on his hand and began to pump Izuku vigorously.

Izuku screwed his eyes shut as Katsuki's large hand enclosed around his whole length.

There was no tenderness to it.

It was rough, hard, and it was full of too many emotions for Izuku to count. Izuku rotated between moaning and hissing as Katsuki squeezed his tip, pressing out a droplet of pre-cum. The spit worked only slightly and Izuku could feel a tremendous amount of friction—but he liked it. A scary amount.

Then with a loud groan from Katsuki, he captured Izuku's mouth again. They kissed hungrily as Katsuki switched from pumping him alone, to pumping their cocks together in a vigorous motion.

They both were drowned in gratification as they moaned into the sloppy kiss. Their pulsing lengths slotted together in feverish want. Katsuki squeezed their tips together and Izuku jolted against the zip tie as waves of elation crashed into him. Their dribbles of pre-cum mixed and Katsuki's thumb smeared the sensitive slit of Izuku's cock.

Izuku's toes curled, and his eyes rolled back.

"Th-There's lube—" Izuku gasped into the kiss, and his words were drowned in a hungry groan from Katsuki. "There's lube in the bottom drawer—"

Katsuki didn't stop kissing him or pumping their cocks as he dropped his knife. He began to clumsily fumble his hand towards the nightstand. He ripped open the bottom drawer and hastily felt around until he seized the bottle of lube.

They continued to kiss like they were lost in deep desolation as Katsuki uncapped the bottle with one hand. Izuku felt Katsuki's fingers start to head towards where he loved them the most.

He lifted his hips eagerly and Izuku keened when a generous amount of lube was applied to his awaiting hole. He waited for Katsuki's fingers to slip in as his body trembled with excitement.

But his eyes bulged wide when he felt the cold handle of Katsuki's knife press at his entrance.

Izuku's head snapped up but in the following second, Katsuki wrapped a hand around his throat and slammed his head back down.

Katsuki grabbed his neck in a lover's chokehold.

Izuku roughly exhaled as he was gagged. The handle began to slowly sink in, stretching him open. The danger of it coursed an extraordinary amount of adrenaline through him. With every inch his senses heightened, and Izuku began to feel instantly lightheaded from Katsuki's grasp around his throat.

Katsuki gripped the blade of his knife tightly and angled the handle down.

Izuku immediately gasped as his prostate was struck.

Euphoria lit up his nerves like blazing hot lightning. It captured him, making him tingle all over. Katsuki saw this and gripped his neck tighter, officially cutting off air flow.

Izuku began whimpering as Katsuki hit his sweet spot again and again until he found a rhythm. Every movement jolted him with a wave of mind-numbing pleasure that made his toes curl.

Katsuki's face twisted in a snarl as he bored his eyes into Izuku's sweet face that was contorted with ecstasy. Izuku's body rocked with every thrust and his eyes never left Katsuki's chilling gaze as he was roughly fucked on the handle.

All his limbs began to ignite with nonstop intoxicating rapture. It rolled over him in countless crashing waves that raced from his head to his toes. The sting of the zip tie around his wrists poured into him too, mixing with the elation.

Izuku's head began feeling like he was on cloud nine as Katsuki picked up the pace.

His orgasm built like a growing hellfire in his core with every thrust Katsuki gave. Heat so extreme that he thought he would explode from it. He gasped as a primal need deep inside of him awoke with every push in and pull out. It rattled his rib cage as he was brought closer and closer to the edge by Katsuki.

His belly stirred with fever as he tried to fuck back on the handle. He moaned past the grip around his delicate throat and arched his back as euphoria shot right into his bloodstream.

Izuku called to his husband in a choked-out gasp as his eyes began to roll back.

Katsuki was now feverishly fucking the handle relentlessly against his prostate. He made Izuku arch up and see stars. White dots danced across Izuku's vision as his head was filled with so much pleasure it made him dizzy. He screamed. He moaned. All his muscles tensed as his legs trembled violently.

Katsuki leaned over to watch Izuku's face be drowned in pleasure. He angled the handle just right to make Izuku jolt and quake more intensely. He observed, sadistically satisfied, as Izuku's hole tightened around the handle. Then he groaned when Izuku cried out his name like a wounded animal.

Izuku went cross eyed as he was overstimulated. He hiccupped and yanked against the zip tie several times, moving the bed with force as he tried to break free. Izuku blinked rapidly as his head overflowed with mind shattering pleasure.

What was building in the pits of Izuku's core wasn't like anything before.

He was caught at the highest level of blazing ecstasy as both fear and excitement held him up. He felt like any minute he could—

"—*Cum*," Katsuki harshly demanded. He pushed down the handle into Izuku's prostate with all his strength.

Izuku's body seized up.

His core tightened and the strong hold Katsuki held over him ripped his orgasm out of his body on command.

Izuku's feverish cries broke into a high, broken scream as he peaked. Ribbons of cum spurted out of his throbbing cock and landed across his chest. He sobbed loudly and his body convulsed violently at the unexpected orgasm that was ruthlessly fucked out of him.

Izuku's world went suddenly silent as temporary deafness cut into him. He blinked rapidly at the white noise that overtook his hearing.

His heart rate increased, and he rolled to his side, trying to curl up as he rode out his high.

Then he choked when the handle was replaced with Katsuki's thick cock in an instant. The difference in girth made Izuku moan loudly as Katsuki pushed in. There was zero time for recovery, his orgasm had barely finished, and his senses were being brutally overwhelmed again.

Katsuki grabbed his hair with one hand and with the other, he held the blade to Izuku's throat.

His body shook with unfathomable rapture as Katsuki struck directly against his prostate yet again. Katsuki did it again and again and again, not letting up for a single second as they began to fuck sideways on the ground.

Katsuki immediately set a brutal pace, overstimulating him.

Izuku's limp erection jolted back to life at the feeling of the knife against his throat. With every punch against his prostate, his weeping erection hardened until it was once again pulsing and upright.

The mixed sound of Katsuki's ragged breathing and his own messy cries were the first noises to breach his ears as his hearing came back. The lewd sound of their skin slapping together was next. With every thrust, Izuku's quivering lips spilled a mix of moans and Katsuki's name, as loud pleasure filled cries.

Katsuki's powerful thrusts began to fill with all his emotions.

Izuku felt the frustration, the hurt, the desire and the unchecked rage. With every ram into his sweet spot, Izuku took in every bit of Katsuki's soul. He welcomed all aspects of it as they melded together like two metals in a fire, fusing into one deadly weapon.

He was fucked thoroughly and without pause.

His second orgasm began to build, using the leverage of all his sweltering emotions. It climbed towards the ceiling, pulling him up with it. He pushed back on Katsuki the best he could, dragging the bed with him. Their movements became frenzied as Katsuki plunged in harder, then faster. He moved like he was trying to keep up with his emotions as he drove in and out of Izuku.

Then with a guttural groan, Katsuki gave several powerful staggered thrusts.

He pressed the blade tightly against Izuku's throat and gripped his hair as he came deep inside of him.

Izuku's legs quaked as he was filled up to the brim with Katsuki's cum. It poured across his insides and filled him with so much heat that his vision spotted white.

The euphoria came bombarding forward, ungracefully. It raked up from his toes to his core and down to his fingers. Then it coursed through his core and pulled him up to his second peak. Izuku helplessly cried as his cock spurted out dribbles of cum onto the carpet.

Katsuki cursed as he began grinding into Izuku like he couldn't stop. Izuku could feel he was still painfully hard. And because of that, his body responded like Katsuki's arousal was directly linked to his. His cock twitched again and again.

Izuku grinded backwards full of need. The blood pumping through his veins was filled with pure adrenaline as they rutted against each other.

Izuku heard Katsuki's heavy breathing increase. He then abruptly pulled out and stood up. He lifted the bed up with one hand and freed Izuku from his imprisonment from the bed's leg.

Izuku's rugged breathing grew heavier when instead of freeing his hands, Katsuki retightened the zip tie.

Katsuki then sat on the edge of the bed and planted his feet firmly against the floor.

He spread his legs and lifted Izuku up.

Izuku's head lulled as he was manhandled into Katsuki's lap in a reverse cowboy position. He bit his lip hard as his back hit Katsuki's solid chest and his husband's warm, wet cock slipped between his lubed-up backside.

Izuku barely had time to get his bearings before Katsuki gripped his waist and lifted him up. Izuku's body was hoisted up solely by Katsuki's unprecedented amount of strength. He held Izuku up and then perfectly aligned his tip with Izuku's cum filled hole. Katsuki sank Izuku back onto his awaiting length in a swift motion.

They both moaned loudly as Izuku clenched down in excitement.

Katsuki possessively grabbed a fist full of Izuku's hair with one hand and gripped Izuku's hip with the other in a bruising hold.

Izuku screwed his eyes shut and dropped his mouth as Katsuki began to bounce him up and down. Katsuki maneuvered him easily, like he weighed next to nothing. Izuku moaned loudly as his overused prostate was hit every time, and the sensitivity rippled across his body like rolling thunder. He twitched and jolted and begged for more with quivering limbs.

Every brutal thrust punched out a broken cry from his bleeding lips.

He twisted his hands against the zip tie as Katsuki held on possessively to his hair. Katsuki fucked him harder, faster, and began slamming his hips up to add to the merciless rhythm.

Sweat began dripping profusely all over them as their orgasm began to build again.

Izuku shook uncontrollably as he felt his body become close to putty. Cum dripped down his thighs and he greedily wanted so much more of it to fill him up. He clamped down on Katsuki's pulsing cock and a loud groan from his husband spilled into the air. Izuku did it again and the same response was elicited.

Then when Izuku did it a third time, Katsuki yanked his head back until Izuku choked.

Katsuki pounded into him so viciously that Izuku's whole body was encased with searing hot rapture. It pressed against his core like a blazing hot hand and ripped his next orgasm out of him without hesitation.

Izuku came dry with a scream loud enough to fray his vocal cords. He clamped down on the thick cock inside of him and Katsuki groaned loudly.

Katsuki seized up as he gave one, two, three more ruthless thrusts into Izuku. He held his final thrust up off the bed as he spilled his essence inside of Izuku's tight body. They both gasped as the feeling of hot cum mixed in with the rest that was already inside.

Katsuki dropped back down and fell backwards. Izuku toppled over and they both sighed loudly. Izuku's chest heaved up and down as he tried to catch his breath. His world was spinning, and he was sure he was about to be fucked into oblivion.

Without pulling out, Katsuki rolled their bodies to the middle of the bed and pressed Izuku belly down. Izuku's head hit the soft pillow as he breathed steadily in and out, sweat rolling down all parts of his body.

"We're very far from done, Deku," Katsuki roughly hissed against the shell of his ear. He grinded his hips down in a sensual wind, making Izuku's eyes flutter closed. "Bite a pillow if you need to."

When Katsuki's teeth sunk into his neck, it clicked why passion was always compared to fire. Passion was as insatiable as fire because it needed to endlessly consume in order to stay alive.

So Izuku let Katsuki consume him. He let Katsuki devour him with savage kisses, harsh love bites and possessive tugs of his hair. Every lick, flick, and stroke were a burning need that charred away parts of him—and Izuku wanted to be singed down into nothing.

Katsuki grabbed the headboard and began to fuck him like he hated him.

And Izuku fucked back like he needed it, teeth sinking in the pillow until it ripped.

ɯɯɯ

Izuku awoke to the bright blinding light of the sun spilling into the motel room.

He groaned and shifted while screwing his eyes shut. He sheepishly turned over, facing away from the window as it showered him in sun rays. Instinctively, he put his hand over his eye to block out the light so he could go back to sweet sleep. But he removed his hand slowly when all the events of the previous night came crashing into him gracelessly.

Izuku startled upright, surprised that it was daylight out.

How long had he been asleep? Out of habit, he checked his wrist for the watch that was not there. He winced at the reflex and then tried to search for a clock on the nightstand—but it was laying on the ground next to him, broken.

Izuku began to reorient himself.

He was on the ground, lying tangled in a heap of sheets.

Scattered across the carpet were dozens of glass fragments. They caught the light and sparkled in a threateningly beautiful way.

Izuku then cringed as he looked at the damage to the motel room. All the pictures were knocked off the wall. The bed was moved entirely out of place and slanted downwards. One of the bed's legs had broken because halfway through the night it had buckled under their powerful movements.

In short, the room had been demolished. If someone were to see this same sight, they likely would guess a fearsome storm tore through, leaving nothing whole in its wake. But it was not a storm.

Simply Izuku and Katsuki.

Their outlet of pent-up emotions resulted in hours of sex Izuku didn't think was humanly possible. He recalled the several rounds they had in the bed, against the walls, in the bathroom, and finally on the floor where he was at because at the end, they couldn't make it back to the bed.

Izuku glanced over his shoulder.

On the ground with him in the sheets was Katsuki. He was sitting upright against the wall with his arms folded. From the looks of it, he had been awake for a while. His shoulder from where Izuku had shot him had been wrapped up and tended to. He was chewing on his bottom lip as he stared blankly across the room at the discolored wallpaper.

Izuku moved to join him and immediately flinched when soreness shot up his back.

Izuku gasped lightly and made a pained face. His legs were screaming, and his back muscles were gone. He tried to delicately scoot himself upright, but sitting on his backside was straight out of the question. Instead, he settled for resting on his side. He propped himself up with one arm shakily.

He wasn't going to be able to sit right potentially for a week.

Izuku didn't know what to say. This was not what he anticipated happening at *all*. Far from it, honestly. And judging the way Katsuki was being silent, he didn't anticipate it either.

Katsuki seemed torn between two thoughts that had him in shackling, vice grips. Izuku could practically see Katsuki be physically tugged back and forth.

Izuku didn't blame him. His current emotional state was no better.

The number of mixed feelings twisting awake inside of him was countless. He couldn't even identify half of what he was feeling. It was all one big pile of mush inside of his chest, but all he knew was that he and Katsuki were finally back in each other's orbit—and the gravitational pull was lethally strong.

Katsuki shifted.

He raked a hand through his hair and gripped his roots in frustration. He glanced at Izuku once, stood up and kicked the sheets off to the side.

Izuku's heart clutched as Katsuki began putting on his clothes.

Katsuki kept his back turned towards him as he halfway dressed in his shirt and boxers. He then leaned against the wall across the way from where Izuku was at.

Izuku's heart palpitated.

Katsuki put distance between them.

Izuku now had no clue what was going to happen next. Was Katsuki going to resume hunting him? Was he going to use this weakened moment to kill Izuku while his guard was down and could barely stand? Or was he going to leave him here, and never bother with him again?

The last one seemed like the worst as Izuku stared at Katsuki.

Katsuki stared at him too.

They locked eyes and a sudden onslaught of emotions leaked out. Hurt. Pain. Anger. Longing. Each of these emotions took up too much space in the room, making it feel suffocatingly tight.

Izuku tried to smile, but the gesture wasn't returned. Instead, Katsuki pursed his lips to the side and fiddled with his fingers.

It was here that Izuku thought he heard a noise outside that sounded like a human.

His paranoia spiked because it could very well be Tomura or one of Chisaki's men finally catching up with them after who knows how long has passed.

Izuku skittishly looked at the window, glancing through the sheer curtain for any suspicious shadows.

Katsuki noticed this and followed his gaze.

They both waited a beat and the noise returned.

Izuku relaxed when he registered the sound was the wind simply rustling the trees. False alarm. He visibly deflated and Katsuki raised an eyebrow at him.

"So," Katsuki said simply. He cleared his throat and continued to idly toy with his hands. "Who else are you running from besides me that has you this jumpy?"

Izuku was having difficulty reading what exactly was happening.

There was a wall as high as the ceiling surrounding Katsuki. His eyes were a little blank, and he barely could maintain eye contact now. But Katsuki also seemed…receptive? At least he was talking to him now and not swinging a blade.

Izuku's hopeful heart thumped as he nervously fidgeted with the sheets below him.

“I-I’m likely being hunted by both the Shie Hassaikai and my family now,” Izuku confessed but then cringed. He tilted his head and made a small correction, “rather, the people who used to be my family, I suppose. The Viper Academy. Both are possibly coming for me.”

Katsuki furrowed his brow at that but still didn’t look up. “What did you do for that to happen?”

Izuku now looked down at the sheets. He pressed his lips in a thin line and said, “I stopped an order of the Shie Hassaikai. And in the process, I slaughtered a large chunk of other assassins from my academy. I haven’t run into either the Yakuza or Vipers yet but…it’s only a matter of time.”

Izuku lifted his gaze to look at Katsuki, and Katsuki still was looking down.

“What constitutes a large chunk?” Katsuki asked.

“Over twenty of my siblings,” Izuku answered.

At this, Katsuki’s distant demeanor broke. He whipped his head up, entirely surprised by what he heard.

“*Twenty*?” Katsuki parroted.

Izuku nodded slowly.

“I-I didn’t know many of them,” Izuku amended, but it still made him feel sad. “My unit was always sectioned off from everyone. But I had to kill three from my unit who I was close with the same night of the masquerade. My older brother, older sister, and my favorite brother, who I thought might be capable of saving. But he wasn’t.”

Katsuki was startled and his eyes stretched wide.

“What made you snap like that?” Katsuki whispered a bit sadly.

Izuku looked Katsuki seriously in the eye now. “At the masquerade, five of the people you killed were members of the Chisaki family. That set off a chain reaction and I had no choice but to intervene.”

Katsuki didn’t seem at all remorseful. He asked, “What kind of chain reaction?”

“A deadly one,” Izuku muttered. “Chisaki Kai is *furious* about his family members being killed, Katsuki. He figured out *you* did the massacre and wanted to even the score with the traditional Yakuza punishment: a life for a life. A family member for a family member. But you don’t have any family. Except—” Izuku paused, sucked in a breath and reluctantly pointed to himself. “—Me. Legally.”

At this Katsuki grew visibly confused. “We’re not related.”

“Our, ah, *marriage*,” Izuku muttered with a light blush. “It makes us legally family.”

“Oh.” Katsuki’s whole face sparked with realization. He nodded dumbly. “Right. We’re family. Legally.”

“The marriage certificate was on the public records, and he found it,” Izuku continued to explain. “Because of that, he jumped to the conclusion I had a helping hand in plotting to kill his family and maybe other Vipers. He decided five Vipers had to be killed to balance the scales. A-And then my brother offered to kill the five kids we have.”

Katsuki’s face distorted as if his stomach turned.

“Who thinks of something like that?” Katsuki hissed, disgusted.

“Tomura.”

Izuku spat his brother’s name with so much resentment that even Katsuki seemed taken back. He thought back to when his callous brother told him the kids were going to be killed. How simple it would’ve been for him. Izuku was becoming increasingly jaded as he recounted the indifference in Tomura’s eyes.

“My big brother *Tomura* thinks of something like that,” Izuku hissed, and his throat began to feel sore. “And I-I couldn’t let that happen. I *couldn’t*. I would burn down the whole city of Tokyo before I ever let that happen. So, I killed them. I killed every single snake that stood in my way, got the kids and ran.”

He waited for his throat to clamp up like always when he spoke of things he shouldn’t.

But to his surprise, it didn’t. It was slightly looser for once. The words were flowing with some resistance, but they were not trapped in his airway like they used to be. Izuku was stunned. He examined his emotions and felt his bitterness towards Tomura had grown.

It seemed like the less of an influence Tomura had on him, the more Izuku was able to find his voice.

“And where are the kids now?” Katsuki asked.

“They’re all safe with Nana,” Izuku explained sadly. “She’s taking them home to their families. I-I had luckily found her rather quickly thanks to your help. You, uh, figured out the bulk of the work and I just put in the last piece. Her alias was One For All. I tracked her down and we talked. Then she agreed to help reunite them with their families that they were stolen from. So, even if the Yakuza or Vipers find me, the kids will be safe no matter what.”

Katsuki’s eyes softened with every word Izuku spoke. He was touched, and Izuku could feel it. The blankness in his face receded back to show residual love.

Izuku’s heart skipped a beat.

The affection was so warm as it shined through Katsuki’s eyes. It beckoned to him and all Izuku wanted to do was jump forward.

“You did good,” Katsuki whispered. He squeezed his hands together and gave a pained, short head nod. “I’m…I’m really proud of you.”

“Thank you,” Izuku said quietly.

They held gazes for a long moment and Katsuki blinked back oncoming tears. He pushed the heel of his hand into his watery eye and then hung his head down. His hair shadowed his face as he went back to fidgeting.

Izuku wearily assessed Katsuki as his heart yearned for him. Izuku then sat up a bit more, wincing at the soreness in his backside. He nervously clutched the sheets in his lap.

“But—Katsuki. That’s not all,” Izuku said. “You’re in danger too.”

Katsuki scoffed and shook his head tiredly. “I’ll be fine.”

“No, Katsuki,” Izuku warned seriously and shook his head. “You won’t be. Chisaki very explicitly demanded he wants you *killed* for what you did at the Masquerade. Chisaki kills people who harm his family in creative ways. He’s the head of the Shie Hassaikai for a *reason*. He overhauled seven other Yakuza families and absorbed them into his own in a very violent, sadistic fashion. You need to be extremely careful. You’re in just as much danger as I am.”

“Chisaki is the one that needs to be careful,” Katsuki grumbled under his breath. “I’m more capable than you think.”

Katsuki didn’t seem the least bit threatened or worried. They awkwardly waded in a bit of silence. It was like they were both congested with too many emotions to pick out what exactly to say to the other. Then finally Katsuki exhaled and shook his head.

“Well. What is your next move, Izuku?” Katsuki asked quietly.

“I guess I’m going to keep it moving,” Izuku confessed in a small voice.

He studied Katsuki longingly. Izuku was suddenly trapped at those crossroads.

Izuku quietly confessed, “Um, Nana offered me a spot to go with her. She said she could help me get out permanently, like you wanted me to do originally. B-But that won’t be for another two months.”

There was a long pause.

Katsuki’s shoulders stiffened.

“Are you going to take it?” Katsuki asked.

“I-I’m halfway considering it,” Izuku whispered honestly. “That’s my only option if I want to live an okay life, right? I can’t go back to Tokyo, and I have nowhere else to go. Especially after all the killings I’ve done, I likely need protecting to cover up my past. Th-There’s no place for me anymore.”

Katsuki didn't say a word for a very long time. Instead, he kept his head hung away from Izuku. His shoulders were growing stiffer by the second as he processed the information.

"Are you sure?" Katsuki asked. His voice was low and quiet. "That's what you want to do?"

Izuku took a long pause as well. Something about this felt wrong.

But still, he said, "I think it is."

Another tense long pause.

"Okay," Katsuki said. His voice was tight. "Let me help you then."

Izuku perked up, and love leapt out of his chest. He stared at Katsuki who still had his head down. Izuku's heart began pounding and the drumming of his pulse shot through his ears.

"R-Really?" Izuku whispered, hoping this wasn't some cruel trick. "You want to help me?"

"Yeah," Katsuki said. He wrung his hands tighter. "Just lay low for two months, right? We can figure out a way to stay out of sight together. I can withdraw some cash to help us go dark and I have my motorcycle we can get around on easily. It'll be safer with the two of us rather than you trying to do this alone."

Izuku searched Katsuki's body language to see if he was being genuine.

But it was hard since Katsuki was still being standoffish. However, Izuku figured Katsuki was being like this for a rightful reason. Clearly even with the explanation in his letter, Katsuki had still been so deeply hurt by everything.

"Thank you, Katsuki," Izuku said gratefully. "Nana gave me the address for a place I could stay at in the meantime. It's called Midnight Sento, it's in a small town not too terribly far from here. It's a bathhouse run by someone she knows who can house us."

"This is nice of her," Katsuki muttered. But then he pursed his lips and tilted his head. "But *realistically*, you're going to need better security than laying low at a bathhouse. If you're going to stay out of their hands for two whole months, you need protection. Likely from trained, lethal bodyguards. I know my ex-supervisor has a safe harbor not too far from here. You'll be better protected in a place with other hitmen who are trained similarly to me."

Izuku chewed his bottom lip.

Katsuki was right.

Nana, while kind, did not have the same training to go up against forces like the ones he needed to stay away from. To depend on her associate, who he didn't know very well, would be risky. The friend could be just as kind, but kindness wouldn't be able to stop the Yakuza or Vipers.

Katsuki, however, had worked bodyguard assignments all his life. His company dealt in both lethal and protective services, and that was perfect for what Izuku needed.

“Would your ex-supervisor be okay with me using his safe house?” Izuku asked nervously. “Last I checked your old company also had a kill order on me.”

“I’m sure that’s settled by now. But if it’s not, I’ll just beg him,” Katsuki grumbled. “The old man has a soft spot for me.”

“Thank you so much, Katsuki.” Izuku then smiled sadly. “But what are you going to do? I know you think you can take on Chisaki head on, but he has a lot of connections all over Japan. Getting close to him isn’t going to be a simple thing—and neither is getting away. Y-You might need Nana’s help disappearing too now,” Izuku suggested meekly. “It’s something you should consider.”

“The only thing I am considering is killing Chisaki,” Katsuki pushed back with a bite. “You don’t need to worry about me, Izuku. I can handle myself just *fine.* I've taken care of myself my whole life. The only thing you need to worry about is laying low. So. Let’s get a move on to that safe house.”

The tone was sharp.

Izuku averted his eyes down to his lap and backed off.

“Okay.” Izuku nodded quietly. “Thank you again for being willing to help.”

“Don’t mention it.”

Katsuki reached over into his backpack, pulled out his navy-blue phone and flipped it open.

“I’ll be right back. I’m going to go make the call to get us set up,” Katsuki said. “Start getting ready to head out.”

“O-Okay.”

Katsuki stood up, grabbed his pants and put them on. He fastened the buttons and then headed to the door. He didn’t spare a look back as he walked, began dialing a number, opened the door and shut it.



While Katsuki was on the phone, Izuku was suffering from whiplash.

It was making his head spin how much Katsuki had simmered down. But even more so—his mind was reeling from the fact that Katsuki couldn’t kill him. He had the perfect opportunity, and he couldn’t do it. Even with Izuku trying to guide him to it.

In the end, Katsuki was just like Izuku.

But even more surprising, Izuku hadn’t expected this offer to help him. It seemed odd, and Izuku felt deeply undeserving of it. Because really, Katsuki didn’t need to do this. He could leave him at this hotel and decide Izuku was a thing of the past.

But instead, Katsuki was helping him.

How soft Kacchan was. Even through all this hurt, he still was abundantly soft at the core.

As he thought about all of this, Izuku tried to clean up despite his aching backside.

He felt bad for the motel owners. Him and Katsuki really did always leave a mess whenever they collided. Izuku neatly put the sheets back on the bed, and carefully put all the glass shards into a pile. He hung the pictures back up and winced when they immediately fell.

Next, he showered and got dressed in some of the clothes Nana provided him. He did his best to scrub out the blood in his winter coat. A faint stain was left though. No matter how much he tried to scrub out the red tint, a hint of it was still there.

By the time Katsuki finished his call, Izuku was waiting politely on the side of the bed.

Katsuki entered the room apprehensively. He met Izuku's gaze for about five seconds, then averted his eyes.

"Let's head out," Katsuki said quietly. He grabbed his coat and didn't bother to shower. "We're already going to be pushing it. The safe house is located on Oshima Island, which is fairly far south. It's about a five-hour drive, and the last ferry out to the island is in six hours."

Izuku nodded in understanding. "Okay."

He grabbed his duffle bag and stood up, ready to leave.

Katsuki began walking out of the room and Izuku followed behind him.

As they walked outside, Izuku noted how it was getting colder. Winter was approaching a bit faster than usual this year, and Izuku kept relating it back to bad omens. He tried not to shiver when some of the fierce wind snuck into his coat.

When they reached Katsuki's motorcycle, Katsuki began to unlock one of the storage compartments that was hooked on the side. He popped it open to reveal his backpack. Then he shuffled through all that to grab a black helmet. He handed it to Izuku without meeting his eye.

"Remember to hang on tight and lean with me," Katsuki said distantly. He kept his eyes focused on Izuku's neck that was covered in hickeys, refusing to look up at him. "If you need to pee, just tap me on the shoulder."

"Okay," Izuku said in acknowledgment.

Katsuki then turned around and began putting on his own helmet.

As he did this, Izuku's heart hurt a bit.

There was a specific pain that came with Katsuki not meeting his gaze.

Izuku followed the pull in his heart and reached his hand out. But when he saw how tense Katsuki's shoulders were, he stopped himself. He retracted his hand and clutched it to his chest. Izuku, disheartened, looked down to the ground.

He put his helmet on while gazing at the back of Katsuki's head. Katsuki got on the bike, punched in his GPS and started up the engine. He kicked the stand up in a fluid motion and Izuku began to secure his duffle bag to his person.

Izuku hopped on the back of Katsuki's motorcycle and immediately winced. He awkwardly shifted forward to ease some of the pressure from his tailbone and hooked his arms around Katsuki's midsection.

Immediately Katsuki tensed under his touch.

Izuku's stomach sank.

He bit his lip and quietly asked, "D-Do you want to talk?"

Or scream. Or yell, Izuku thought. Anything other than this.

"No." Katsuki rejected.

Izuku grew hesitant, but he had no time to disagree. Katsuki took off and Izuku held on tightly to him. They rode off at a swift speed in silence with the roaring winds following them.

ᔓᔓᔓ

The whole trip went smoothly because, well, Katsuki refused to engage with him.

It was hard to have a rocky time when there was no conversation. Izuku did his best not to say anything about it. He wasn't exactly in a position to push Katsuki into doing anything. But it was hard to ignore how much it hurt to be stone-walled by Katsuki.

The part of him that loved Katsuki more than air wanted to mend things—but the reasonable side of him told him to shut up and be grateful. He killed this man's mother who he loved dearly. It was a miracle Katsuki wasn't still trying to murder him for his part in everything.

So. Izuku didn't say anything.

During pit stops they didn't speak.

During the ride they didn't talk.

Even at red lights, not a word was exchanged.

Katsuki didn't meet his gaze at all and Izuku felt like he was being strangled in a much crueler way now.

They had about an hour left currently before they reached the port. At this rate, they were going to make the ferry—but as if fate had seen everything running a bit too smoothly, a literal obstacle fell into their path.

Both Izuku and Katsuki frowned when the traffic grew denser into the rural region they were heading towards. Izuku peaked from over Katsuki's shoulder and saw a long string of cars all sitting impatiently.

The sun was going down, yet no one was moving.

"What the hell is going on?" Katsuki harshly whispered as they came to a complete halt.

Katsuki tilted slightly and it was here they witnessed cars beginning to turn around and go other directions. Others began following those vehicles, and soon there were a handful of people turning back.

"Oh, fuck this," Katsuki muttered. "Let me go see what the holdup is."

Without wasting time, Katsuki began maneuvering his bike through the narrow spaces between cars. He earned some honks in the process but didn't give a single damn. He flippantly waved people off as he pushed through.

Izuku smiled a bit, he missed this. He always adored Katsuki's slightly crass attitude when it came to getting things done.

Katsuki cut his way through the traffic to reach the source of the problem. And when they did, it made both of their mouths drop wide with shock.

Police were everywhere, urging impatient people to back up.

Behind the officers on the narrow road was a string of trees that had toppled over. Their roots were torn from the ground, looking like a giant had tried to pluck them up. Amid all the blown over trees were several cars, trapped. They were piled up in a crash and one looked like it had rolled over entirely.

One officer with a notepad approached them when they saw Katsuki inch a bit too close. He put his hands up and motioned for them to back up.

"Sorry, but I'm going to need you to turn around like everyone else," the officer said firmly. "This road is closed. The high winds caused the trees to overturn and, in the process, trapped a couple of cars."

"Is there any way we can just get through?" Katsuki asked. He looked behind the officer at the chaos. "We're on a motorcycle we can weave around the debris—"

"—Sorry. No exceptions. You're going to have to turn around."

“But we need to go *this* way, it’s the only direct path there. We’re going to miss the ferry in the next hour.”

“I’m sorry sir, I can’t help you,” the officer reinforced. “The only thing we can suggest is following the rest of the detour. You’ll have to go around the mountain pass to get to where you need to go.”

The police officer pointed in the entirely opposite direction. Katsuki looked behind him at the rows and rows of cars now stuck in traffic trying to go the other way. He groaned loudly and dropped his head.

“You’ve got to be fucking kidding me,” Katsuki spat. But he did as he was instructed. “Always fucking something.”

ᔓᔓᔓ

They made it to the ferry too late.

Izuku bit his lip and Katsuki cursed loudly as they saw the boat take off right as they arrived. They stared at it and Izuku suddenly now felt nervous. The sun had set fully. It had officially been three days since he ran away, and that meant Tomura was likely drawing closer with each passing second.

Katsuki frustratingly put down the kick stand with his foot and hopped off the bike.

Izuku took off his helmet and shook his hair and then swung his legs over to one side of the bike. He leaned against it apprehensively, watching as their ferry sailed away without them into the dark ocean.

So much for getting to safety by the end of the night.

Izuku turned his attention to Katsuki.

Izuku watched as the agitated man snatched off his helmet and began typing in something on his navy-blue phone. He scrolled a bit angrily. Then he gave a long, tired sigh.

“Well. That really was the last ferry out to the island,” Katsuki announced, entirely annoyed. He held his helmet between his arm and his hip and leaned his weight onto one foot. “The next one isn’t going to be until 07:00 in the morning. We’re going to have to spend the night somewhere in the meantime.”

“At least we’re where we need to be,” Izuku tacked on, attempting to look on the bright side.

He gazed out to the land mass in the dark distance. His heart fluttered at the sight. His safety was just across that horizon. They were so close yet so far.

He turned his eyes to Katsuki, who still wouldn’t meet his gaze. Izuku tried to ignore how that made his heart clutch.

“Let’s hurry and grab a hotel,” Katsuki said. “I think I saw one back that way.”

“Erm, would it be okay if we do not go to a hotel?” Izuku asked in a single breath.

“What else would we do, sleep in the trees?” Katsuki asked sarcastically. “You got something against sleeping on a bed all of a sudden?”

Izuku winced and said, “I’ve been thinking about how a hotel room is hard to escape once you get cornered in it.”

At that, Katsuki scoffed under his breath. “You don’t say?”

“I would just feel better if we were in a place that’s a bit more likely not to get checked,” Izuku continued, ignoring the attitude. “I feel like motels and hotels are the first place the Vipers and Yakuza would look for us. Let’s try somewhere that wouldn’t be easy to guess.”

“So, you want to sleep in an abandoned building is essentially what you’re saying?”

“No. It doesn’t have to be an abandoned building. But maybe just not another sketchy motel.”

Katsuki sucked at his teeth. He rolled his eyes a bit then nodded as if he did agree. He gazed past Izuku tiredly into the dark distance.

“I think I saw what looked like a water tower not too far from here,” Katsuki suggested. “We can go there if that’ll make you more comfortable. It’s secluded, a good shelter from this bitter ass cold, and no one would be looking for us in there, I’m sure.”

Izuku perked up.

“That would work perfectly.” Izuku nodded. He held his arm and tilted his head at Katsuki. “Thank you for, ah, listening to me.”

Katsuki shrugged. “Yeah, whatever.”

Izuku chewed on his cheek.

His chest was beginning to feel uncomfortably tight. The pain inside of him was growing stronger the longer Katsuki was this frigidly withdrawn.

He couldn’t stop himself from what he did next. Katsuki had been looking down to the ground, and Izuku tried to tilt his head to meet Katsuki’s line of vision—but Katsuki turned his head away before they could connect gazes.

Izuku was stunned at the ornery action.

Katsuki put his helmet back on, slightly irritated. He got back on the bike and pushed up the kickstand.

“Let’s go,” Katsuki said distantly. “It’s getting late.”

Izuku hesitantly got back on the bike too. He shuffled in close, and the warmth from Katsuki's body heat contrasted the cold shoulder he was dealing with.

As he hooked his arms around Katsuki, once again, Katsuki stiffened.

Izuku's heart began singing a sad hymn.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When they made it to the abandoned water tower, it was exactly what Katsuki said: secluded.

It was tall, rusted over a bit and there was a long, intimidating ladder that led to the top. Katsuki parked his bike off to the side in a row of nearly barren bushes and pulled out his backpack from the storage compartment. He hooked it over his shoulder and gestured with his head for Izuku to follow him.

They climb up the wobbly ladder with Katsuki leading.

The whole way up, the wind howled, pushing at higher speeds the further up they went.

When they finally made it to the top, they found themselves on a metal walkway. It circled all the way around the cylinder structure. Izuku stopped to look out across the horizon while Katsuki began searching for a way in.

He couldn't help but want to take in the sights.

He could see out across the small city they were in, and he wondered briefly if this could be some of his last moments in Japan. From up here, Izuku could see sprinkles of white and yellow light spilling from windows scattered across the night scene. There was sparse greenery in between all the small buildings that was slowly dying with the oncoming winter.

His eyes gazed up to the vast sky above.

The darkness here was deeper than any of the major cities, allowing for a clear view of the constellations. All the stars and planets mirrored dazzling glitter dusted across the atmosphere like a painting. Izuku turned his head to look over towards the ocean. His hair tussled with the breeze as he noted the water perfectly reflected the sky above, making it look like it was a sea of stars.

Had this been any other night, this could be considered romantic. But there was none of that now.

Izuku was beginning to lose his grip on his hopeless romantism.

"I found the door," Katsuki announced from around the corner.

Izuku turned his attention back to where it mattered. He followed Katsuki's voice and paced along the wobbly walkway.

Katsuki expertly picked the lock on the handle. The door popped open rather quickly and together they dragged the heavy obstacle open.

A gentle, blue light spilled out from inside.

Izuku peered in apprehensively.

The tower had a high level of water, and sitting at the bottom were blue lights that gave the liquid a magical glow. Suspended above it was an expanded metal flooring and a control station off to the side. The door led out directly into the metal floor level and there were more stairs up to a second floor.

Carefully, Katsuki took the first step in. He tested the sturdiness of the metal and when it checked out, he motioned for Izuku to come. Izuku climbed in and Katsuki closed the door behind them. The smell of moisture filled his senses as Izuku peeked through the flooring to the glowing water below.

He looked towards Katsuki at this moment. His breath caught a bit.

Katsuki was glancing down, studying the liquid below. The reflection of the water and light bounced off his cheek bones in a lovely manner. The blue contrasted his eyes but matched the distant gaze inside of them.

“The ambience here is sort of nice,” Izuku said gently. His voice echoed off the metal walls. “The light from the water looks pretty cool in here.”

Katsuki nodded dully. “Mhm.”

Izuku deflated slightly.

He pursed his lips to the side at the lack of reaction, but reminded himself that he had no real reason to be upset. Katsuki didn’t have to give him a response. Or a smile. Hell, Katsuki didn’t have to be doing this. He could have kept going with his mission to kill Chisaki, but here he was instead helping Izuku as a detour on his road towards revenge.

Katsuki knelt to the ground and shrugged off his backpack and jacket. He began pulling out a large, black sleeping bag from his pack. Izuku noted how the sleeping bag had some leaves and twigs in it like it had been recently used.

Izuku awkwardly kneeled too. He began to rearrange the objects in his duffle bag in an orderly fashion. He put his clothes on top and the harder items on the bottom to create a makeshift pillow.

With a slight huff, Katsuki laid out the sleeping bag. It wasn’t exactly big enough for two people.

Izuku waited for the uncomfortable tango they were about to do.

But instead, Katsuki stood up and turned his back.

“I’m going to go sit outside,” Katsuki muttered. “Don’t wait up.”

He left out before Izuku could respond.

Izuku stared at the door, conflicted. He wanted to follow, but knew he wasn’t welcome. He stared down at the makeshift bed in front of him. With a heavy heart, Izuku tucked himself inside the sleeping bag and rested his head against his duffle bag.

He shifted over, trying his best to leave room for Katsuki if he ever decided to come back in.



Izuku tossed and turned.

He looked at the door and his heart begged him to go out there too.

Then he looked to his side and saw Katsuki’s jacket on the ground.

Instantly, he was transported back to when he first met Katsuki. He saw him shivering in the cold without proper clothes. Without warning, Izuku’s heart really did begin to burn. Katsuki was outside in the winter cold without a jacket.

That was the breaking point for Izuku.

He got up and grabbed the article of clothing. With hesitation, he walked outside meekly, poking his head out the doorway. There he saw Katsuki. His legs were dangling over the side of the ledge as he leaned against the railing. He was gazing out across the tiny city with a distant look in his eyes.

Izuku cleared his throat.

Katsuki cut his eye at him and then immediately huffed. He turned his head away from Izuku coldly.

“Kacc—” Izuku stopped himself and quickly bit his tongue. “Katsuki. You, uh, forgot your jacket. I-It’s cold out here. You might get sick.”

Katsuki grumbled. He held his hand out and Izuku awkwardly gave it to him. Without moving his head, Katsuki put on the jacket aggressively, zipped it up tight and shoved his hands in his pockets.

Izuku nervously shifted on his feet.

“Are you going to stay out here all night?” Izuku asked shyly.

“I’m watching the door,” Katsuki quipped like it was obvious. “You can go back to sleep.”

“I-I can’t sleep.”

“Izuku. Go back inside.”

Katsuki sounded furious. His voice trembled as if he was holding back a thunderstorm inside of him. It broke Izuku's heart to see how much the love they shared disintegrated down into ashes. No, not even ashes. Nothing. It felt like there was now *nothing* between them.

Izuku broke.

He couldn't do this. He thought he could, but he couldn't. He needed Katsuki to speak. He needed him to communicate or take it all out on him. Because while Izuku could accept Katsuki's fiery anger, he absolutely could not deal with his cold shoulder.

He kneeled beside Katsuki and ignored the winds picking up speed. He reached his hand out and finally gripped Katsuki's shoulder.

Katsuki immediately tried to jerk away, but Izuku couldn't let go.

"Please talk to me," Izuku begged. "*Please*. Or look at me."

Katsuki shook his head. He shifted away from Izuku's warmth.

"I *can't* look at you," Katsuki hissed, but not angrily. His voice was hoarse with so much agony like he couldn't take it anymore. "The reason why I can't should be *very* fucking clear."

Izuku shuffled closer again. "I-I know, b-but please. Look at me."

He grabbed Katsuki's jacket and tugged. He begged him to turn around, but Katsuki began shaking his head and resisted.

"No. I can't do it," Katsuki hissed. Izuku pulled again, and Katsuki began losing his composure. "No." A pull. "I said no—" a tug. "*Stop*—"

"*Please*," Izuku's voice cracked.

"No. I can't do it. I can't. If I do it, then—"

"—Then what?"

"Then it'll all come *out*!" Katsuki shouted and his voice echoed fiercely through the night. He kept his body turned and slowly dropped his head between his shoulders. He then whispered, "I won't be able to stop it. Everything sitting inside of me will come out and I don't want that to happen."

"Let it out," Izuku whispered.

Katsuki shook his head. "But I don't want it to—"

"—You have to let it *out*. Please. Just look at me. Let it out and *look at me*. I don't care what happens or what you say. I'll listen and I'll *take* it all because I deserve it. Scream. Yell. Tell me to go to hell—b-but please. Take it out on me."

It took a long time.

Katsuki shook his head at first, resistant to what Izuku had suggested. But then gently, Izuku began to caress his shoulders.

With the help of Izuku's touch, Katsuki's final layer of armor crumbled down. It dropped to the ground to reveal the final layer underneath Katsuki's layers of anger and sadness: heartbreak. He gradually turned towards Izuku, inch by inch as if it pained him too much to do.

Then when his head finally turned and lifted, Izuku's heart shattered into a million pieces.

Tears were already streaming down on Katsuki's cheeks, making his skin shine with wetness. The puffiness around the rims of his eyes was so red it rivaled his irises. And his nose had burned pink from the nipping cold.

It was a harrowing sight. Katsuki was in so much pain it was devouring him from the inside out.

Then Katsuki finally looked him in the eye.

Izuku's heart drowned underneath the weight of Katsuki's hurt. It piled on him immediately, funneling directly into his chest through those searing red eyes.

The lid on all of Katsuki's bottled up emotions came right off.

"How could you, Izuku?" Katsuki's voice cracked on the last syllable of Izuku's name. "H-How could you look me in my eyes for *that long* knowing the truth and not say *anything*? H-How could you find it in yourself to lie after *everything* we shared together? I-I've been trying to wrap my mind around that *specific* fact—but I *can't*."

Katsuki tried to stop his tears. He clenched his jaw and his face crumbled like flimsy paper.

"I keep replaying that last month over and over," Katsuki wept. He shook his head and Izuku stayed quiet. "Then I keep trying to imagine if there was information that was *that* important to you, could I be able to keep it from you for that damn *long*? How could you fucking kiss me, have sex with me, and say *I love you* while knowing you were the one who killed her? How c-could you do all that? W-We talked about our deepest fucking insecurities and *everything*—"

Katsuki choked on his words like they were made of sharp metal. He sobbed more, and Izuku's heart collapsed into itself.

Izuku lowered his head in shame and an avalanche of tears rolled down from his own eyes. He knew Katsuki was right. The last month made him feel disgusting, like he had rolled around in mud and still got in bed with Katsuki every night.

"I-I'm sorry," Izuku said past his own tears. "I'm so *so* sorry. I know that was wrong of me, I-I shouldn't have deceived you like that."

“A sorry isn’t going to make it right, Izuku,” Katsuki sobbed. “You knew my mother was the *one* person my whole world revolved around and still didn’t say anything. You knew how much she meant to me. And I loved you, Izuku. That’s why I couldn’t look at you today. Because every time I look at you, I’m reminded how much I *still* love you despite everything.”

Katsuki’s fist squeezed shut.

“But then every time I look at you, I see this horrible sequence of events that breaks my goddamn heart,” Katsuki confessed. “I see us saying we love each other at my family’s graveyard where my mother’s body is *buried*. I see me saying I trust you right in front of her grave. Then I see me breaking down in the stupid nursery and telling you everything—absolutely *everything*—I’ve gone through. Th-Things I never told anyone else and things I wish I *forgot*. I laid myself bare for you and the honesty wasn’t returned.”

Izuku’s throat became sore. He pressed his hands in his lap and lowered his head.

“I-I’m sorry, I should have been honest with you,” Izuku whispered.

“Yes, *you should have*,” Katsuki agreed with a bite. “Never in my life have I felt this much love for a person, and that *terrifies* me. I thought that ma-maybe you could really be the first person to see me—”

Katsuki clenched his jaw, and his chest began heaving.

“I-I thought that maybe if I was open and honest with you, you wouldn’t see me as this monster like everyone else does,” Katsuki cried. “A-And you told me that night you *didn’t* think I was a monster. B-But still even after all that—”

Katsuki tried to bite his lip to stop the wrecked sob from escaping. But it forced its way out.

It was a cry so mournful like it had been accumulating inside of Katsuki for years. It sounded old, and harrowing.

“E-Even after all of that, when I asked you why you didn’t tell me the truth,” Katsuki cried. “You looked at me and all you saw was a monster. Y-You were scared. You were scared that if you told me the truth, I would hurt you. So why should I ever try to be anything *different*? Everyone I’ve ever cared about thinks I am this horrible, evil thing!”

Izuku shook his head. “K-Kacchan—”

“—But on top of that, you just *left* so abruptly too,” Katsuki hissed. “Knowing I have issues with abandonment! Yo-You didn’t even say *goodbye* properly because you thought I was a *monster*!”

He spoke over Izuku, and his words began to pick up speed. He whirled his hurt eyes on Izuku and now the sharpened blade of blame was laying inside of them.

“A-And then I woke up *alone* and *paralyzed* for *hours*!” Katsuki sobbed. “I was trapped in my fucking head for ages, crying out for you! B-But worst of all, you just nonchalantly left

that fucking folder there for me to see! Wh-Why would you do that? Why would you think *that* was the way to tell me the truth, hah?! Why was I not good enough for a decent fucking conversation after I gave my heart to you?!"

Izuku had been intensively listening to every word Katsuki said, agreeing with each listed grievance.

However, his attention snagged on one particular word.

"Folder?" Izuku parroted.

Katsuki glared at him through his tears.

"Yes," Katsuki said. He leaned into Izuku's face, snarling. "The fucking folder you *left* on the kitchen table where you let me see how much you were *paid* to kill her."

Izuku blinked rapidly and leaned back. "What? I didn't leave a folder—"

"—Yes, you *did*," Katsuki yelled back angrily. He glowered fully, clearly pissed off that Izuku might be lying. "The red folder that was signed and approved by your fucking *boyfriend*. Which is the cherry on top of all of this shit, by the way," Katsuki hissed rapidly as his eyes went wild with hurt.

Katsuki kept going, gaining speed in letting out all his bottled-up feelings.

But Izuku was stuck, trying to piece together what the hell Katsuki was talking about.

"Because even after you abandoned me and left that folder I still tried to come and find you to talk to! I-I spent a *week* nonstop searching around Tokyo! I even went down in that dangerous ass underground because I was worried sick about you! I had no clue if you were *safe* because you didn't even bother to leave any contact information!"

With a bewildered expression, Izuku attempted to connect the dots. But several things were not adding up.

"But imagine my surprise when people knew exactly who you were and told me you were likely with *Chisaki*," Katsuki spat viciously. "The beautiful Viridian Viper and the goddamn Yakuza Heir: a perfect match made in *Hadeus*. And all these people were *gushing* about your budding romance and—"

"—Wa-Wait," Izuku said loudly over Katsuki.

Katsuki glared but stopped speaking. He waited impatiently for Izuku to say something.

"Katsuki—I explained the situation about Chisaki in my letter," Izuku whispered, slightly hurt. "There is no budding romance, wh-why would you ever believe that? I told you Chisaki bought my virginity against my will and my brother was forcing me to sleep with him."

With that, Katsuki's anger faltered.

His nose scrunched up and he looked at Izuku sideways.

“What letter?” Katsuki asked.

Izuku blinked.

“The letter I put in your hands after I left,” Izuku explained. “It was in a white envelope. I signed it with your name on it and everything.”

There was a long stretch of silence as the wind cut through them.

Katsuki’s anger slowly but surely was replaced with confusion. Katsuki leaned back. He stared at Izuku with increasing perplexity.

“What are you talking about?” Katsuki questioned. “There was no letter. You left the red folder. Not a letter. And it wasn’t in my hands, it was in the kitchen.”

“No. I didn’t,” Izuku shot back. He looked at Katsuki sideways too. “I left a *ten page* letter, explaining *everything* including the truth about your mother. I put it right between your fingers so when you woke up you would have it. I-I even put my cell phone number inside so you could call me if you wanted to.”

Katsuki’s mouth hung open, but no words came out.

His eyes darted off to the side, searching his memory.

Then he frowned deeper.

“…Izuku,” Katsuki said slowly. “I didn’t get a letter. There was nothing in my hands when I woke up.”

“But I put it in your fingers right before I left,” Izuku replied. His heart began hammering as the wind picked up. “A-And I never had access to archived folders. I had only seen your mother’s folder *once*. It was never in my possession. I couldn’t have left it.”

Katsuki blinked. “Then who did?”

They stared at each other, baffled.

They searched each other’s eyes, trying to find a lie. But they found no hint of deception. They were both telling the truth.

Now, a giant spotlight shined down on the rift between them. It was as wide as an ocean and full of countless, invisible gaps in information. If what the other was saying was true, then Izuku’s letter somehow disappeared while Mitsuki’s red folder magically took its place. And given the contents, it couldn’t have been a coincidence.

In that silence, it clicked for both of them. There was a horrible, malicious swap made.

Izuku furrowed his brow when he could only think of one culprit.

“I think…I think I know who did it,” Izuku whispered gravely. “My sister, Himiko. She must’ve switched them.”

Anger bit at the inside of Izuku’s chest.

He made a pained face as if he had been sucker punched ten times. Then he let out a shaky exhale and frustratingly scrubbed his hands down his face. He held his head in his hands to keep from screaming.

Of course. Of. Fucking. *Course*.

Himiko knew about Katsuki, and she had heard *everything*. Izuku reflected on the day he left the estate. He recalled when Tomura let him take a stroll around before they left. Izuku had taken his time, having difficulty departing. But when they did this, Himiko was in the car.

However, she clearly had come on a mission of her own and not stayed seated the whole time. And just like a true snake, she had discreetly bitten both Izuku and Katsuki with a lethal dose of venom.

Izuku lifted his head from his hands. Katsuki seemed entirely lost.

Suddenly now all the string of events from the last month made sense. Terrible, *cruel* sense. No wonder Katsuki hadn’t *called*. He hadn’t gotten his number. Or closure. Or even knew what really had happened. Did Katsuki even know about the divorce papers? Did he even *get* them?

Now Izuku was questioning *everything*.

Like a slap to the face, Izuku realized Katsuki knew nothing. That means if Katsuki never knew about Chisaki’s arrangement, then that means he witnessed Izuku pull down Chisaki for that kiss with no context. Katsuki probably watched them slow dance and saw the way Chisaki suggestively pawed at him and how Izuku let it happen.

But worst of all, this meant Katsuki learned about the truth of his mother through a red folder.

Izuku was now incredibly upset.

No *wonder* Katsuki was so hell bent on hunting him down—

“Hold on.” Katsuki’s eyes narrowed. The newfound confusion entirely overshadowed every other emotion they had just been feeling. “How many siblings do you have *exactly*? And why would she do something like that?”

Izuku cringed.

As he stared at Katsuki, he could see the enormous amount of information missing.

“I technically have about two hundred other siblings,” Izuku whispered.

Katsuki's eyes startled wide and he blinked rapidly.

"And she did it because she hates me," Izuku explained simply. "She wants to see me suffer for killing someone she cared about in our cohort. Our upbringing…it punishes compassion and empathy. The only thing she's ever known is pain and negative emotions. As a result, she's been holding on to resentment against me all her life to keep her going. So, this swap… it makes sense why she did it. She wanted to hurt me—hurt us."

Katsuki was stunned into silence.

As Katsuki stared at Izuku, all the anger in his watery eyes steadily quelled.

"You…You really left me a letter?" Katsuki asked in a strangled tone. "A ten paged one?"

"Ye-Yeah," Izuku whispered.

Izuku met Katsuki's eyes again, and the raw pain in both of their faces was potent. As the misalignment came into light, they both were equally horrified.

Izuku's heart churned bitterly.

Oh, how well Himiko had played this one, he thought. She got what she wanted, and Izuku was officially exiled. He was on the run, and she successfully turned the love of his life against him in the most vicious way possible—and she also destroyed Katsuki's heart in the process.

All with the simple switch of a letter and a folder.

He had to give it to her. She truly was a Viper.

"Wh-What was in the letter?" Katsuki asked. He looked aghast.

"*Everything*," Izuku sobbed, and his face crumbled. He couldn't stop the tears from coming out of him when he realized how hurt Katsuki must've been to find that folder. "I-I explained everything regarding your mother's death. I detailed the whole incident. I explained why I needed to go back to Tokyo for the kids. I even wrote about how Chisaki bought my virginity, and I was planning on killing him for you."

Katsuki's eyes stretched wider and wider with every sentence Izuku spoke.

Izuku kept going. The words were pressed out of him by the immense amount of sadness he was feeling.

"You're right about how I couldn't find a way to tell you," Izuku confessed. "My brother Tomura had come to the estate when you were away at your retirement party. He revealed the truth to me, and I broke down in a way I hadn't before. I-I hadn't known she was your mother, and when I did, I couldn't believe I played a part in hurting you that much. Then Tomura warned me not to tell you. He told me you would kill me if I did."

Izuku's pained expression tripled as he gazed down at his scarred hands.

“A-And Tomura has always had this frightening hold over me—” Izuku choked. “And because of that, there’s a piece of me that will probably always believe he has my best interest in mind since he’s saved my life so much. S-So when he told me not to say anything…”

Izuku trailed off, he couldn’t repeat his biggest mistake out loud.

“…You didn’t,” Katsuki finished for Izuku. “You listened to him.”

Izuku nodded mournfully.

“Th-That’s why I wrote the letter,” Izuku whispered. “I-I figured if I couldn’t say it out loud, I could try to in words. I-I read in a lot of books how characters gave each other these long romantic letters when words were too hard to say. And I thought it would be the next best option since I didn’t know what to do. I knew you deserved closure, but a large part of me was still underneath Tomura’s thumb. So, I mimicked what I saw in my favorite book to h-help me. L-Like I always do.”

Izuku lifted his gaze.

Katsuki was drenched in distress.

“B-But I know now, I should have spoken up and told you,” Izuku said sincerely. “I shouldn’t have pretended because if I had just—If I just gave you the same honesty back, none of this would have happened. Himiko wouldn’t have been able to swap the letter out and you wouldn’t have been hurt the way you are now.”

Katsuki didn’t say anything.

His eyes were darting all over Izuku, staring at him in such a heartbreaking way. Izuku half expected him to get up, call him stupid, and march back into the water tower.

But instead, Katsuki drew closer. He scooted in until their bodies were touching. He then carefully turned towards Izuku head on and then lifted his shaky hands. Katsuki then held Izuku’s face gently—just like he used to.

Izuku broke all the way down. He missed this touch.

He lifted his hands up to hold Katsuki’s wrists, and screwed his eyes shut. He dropped his head, but Katsuki kept it held up. Izuku tried to slow his crying as Katsuki forced their gazes to maintain contact.

“Izuku,” Katsuki said firmly in a hoarse voice. “I need you to tell me *everything* you’ve gone through from start to finish.”

Izuku held Katsuki’s wrists tighter. He became apprehensive on reflex.

“Izuku, *please*,” Katsuki begged when he felt the hesitance. He drew in close. “I need to know *everything*, leave out no details. I-I need to hear the *whole* story so I can grasp the full picture of what’s going on with you. C-Can you do that for me?”

With the help of the soft touch, Izuku felt like he could.

He held on tightly to Katsuki for courage as he said his next words.

“O-Okay,” Izuku agreed despite his instilled terror. “I-I can try, for you.”

Katsuki nodded frantically. He quickly stood up and pulled Izuku with him. There was an urgency in his action that Izuku hadn’t seen before. Katsuki clutched his hand tightly as he led them back inside of the tower.

He shut the door tight.

ᔓᔓᔓ

It took several long hours for Izuku to go through everything. And the entire time, Katsuki held on to his hand and helped him through it.

When Izuku needed to take a break, Katsuki let him. When Izuku stumbled on the harder parts—Katsuki was there to encourage him. They worked together in tandem to allow Izuku to get past his instilled silence.

They held hands through every grueling detail.

Izuku told it all and tried his best not to skip on any horrifying details no matter how much his throat wanted to clamp shut. But with Katsuki’s comforting aid, Izuku was able to explain his upbringing.

He discussed how they were raised and the entire Viper system: he explained how they lived very rich lives. They had the finest things, and they all lived in what was essentially a luxury apartment compound. But he explained that while on the outside they owned everything they could think of, it came with a heavy price.

And that price was their humanity.

He explained how they were punished for having positive feelings and displaying affectionate physical touch. He discussed the basement of torture for punishments. Then he talked about how Tomura had taken over his punishments when he was thirteen. He explained the belts, and then he explained the glass box that Tomura now preferred.

When he described how frequently he would be pushed to the brink of famine, Katsuki looked visibly ill.

He explained every part about The Cull. Then he discussed all his closest siblings—including Hiryu. That was a detail that seemed to make Katsuki extremely surprised then sad when Izuku explained why he had been designated for termination.

Izuku forced himself to talk about Tomura, Inko, and Nine. He explained his mental block, and why he couldn’t pull the trigger in Vienna or land a lethal blow in Taiwan.

Then he walked Katsuki through everything relating to his mother. Izuku told him of The Incident with graphic vividness so that Katsuki had all the closure he needed. It was here that Katsuki asked questions, and it pained them both to walk through it.

But they did.

They walked through it together.

Then Izuku explained in deep detail how Tomura sold his body to Chisaki in exchange for power. Then he explained how Tomura had been grooming him for the last five years to be married off to the Yakuza as a trophy so they could merge.

And finally, Katsuki had been stunned into silence as Izuku recounted the last event: him brutally massacring his own kin after the masquerade.

By the end of Izuku's life story, Katsuki was mortified.

Katsuki was staring at him now with so much pity and sorrow. But above all—understanding.

Katsuki's grip on his hand was tight and his fingers were trembling. But Izuku couldn't tell if Katsuki was trembling from sadness or anger. Maybe it was a mixture of both.

"Izuku. Has anything in your life ever been your choice?" Katsuki asked, entirely pained.

Izuku smiled sadly. He looked at the way the blue light painted across Katsuki's handsome face.

"Choosing to love you was," Izuku whispered like it was still a secret.

Katsuki's eyes softened.

They stared at each other with bittersweet melancholy as all the gaps were filled in.

"What would happen if they caught you now?" Katsuki asked, terribly afraid.

"I'm sure my Big Brother Tomura would force me to marry Chisaki somehow," Izuku answered. Sourness churned in his chest as he pictured the two men he now despised the most. He could feel their cold gazes burning into him and picking him apart. "He's probably with Chisaki now, convincing him I'm still worth *owning*."

Katsuki frowned a bit.

He tilted his head slowly. He opened his mouth, closed it. Then he looked off to the side as if a final piece of a puzzle was missing.

"What do you mean he's *with* Chisaki?" Katsuki asked carefully. "I thought you said you killed him."

"Huh?" Izuku tilted his head. "When did I say that?"

“Back at the motel, you said you killed your older brother.”

Izuku paused for a moment. Then he realized where Katsuki was misled.

“Oh, no. Sorry,” Izuku quickly apologized. “The nomenclature is all a bit confusing. Jin is who I killed. He was the agent named The Double Headed Viper. Jin is my *older* brother because he was a cohort above me. But my *Big Brother*, the person who oversaw raising me, is Tomura. He’s the one who beheaded our original handler, Nine, and took his position.”

“So, your current handler is…your Big Brother?” Katsuki clarified. “The one who has been hurting you your whole life is *also* your handler?”

“Yes.” Izuku hunched a bit. “I, uh, never realized that could be mixed up. The relationships inside of the Vipers are a little muddled I guess from the outside perspective. Bigs are in charge of a kid from the cohort below them, and they’re called Littles. So, Tomura was my Big and I was his Little. He raised me since I was two and he was seven.”

Katsuki blinked several times. “That’s…so young.”

“It was,” Izuku agreed. “B-But, yeah. Tomura has always controlled everything in my life—and I’m pretty sure the second he gets his hands on me he’s going to punish me. And then he’s going to send me off with Chisaki in order to appease him so he can get his merge. He needs me to complete his plans.”

Katsuki’s eyes began watering again. “I-Izuku, I’m so fucking sorry.”

“I’m sorry too,” Izuku whispered. His eyes began watering as well.

They studied each other. All the strenuous, unfiltered emotions they were feeling poured out.

Izuku looked at the man he loved and finally understood how much of a lifeboat Katsuki had been in his life. This whole time, Katsuki was the single raft who had kept him from succumbing to the darkness he was raised in. And still—even with that—Izuku wound up hurting him.

“I-I’m so sorry for everything, Kacchan,” Izuku said through his hoarse voice. “I-I’m sorry I didn’t say anything about your mom. I should have. She was so important to you, and I knew that. All this mess is my fault because I couldn’t see past how Tomura doesn’t always actually know what’s best for me—or even *want* what’s best for me.”

Izuku cried and Katsuki cried too. Izuku gripped tightly onto Katsuki and hung his head.

“I-It took losing you for me to really understand that a-and I’m so sorry about your mom,” Izuku apologized from the bottom of his being. “I-I wish I hadn’t taken the shot—I-I wish I didn’t do it, but I *did*. I did and now I hurt you. A-And I take full responsibility for my part in it. I understand if you could never see me the same—and I don’t blame you if y-you don’t want to speak again after th-this.”

Katsuki screwed his eyes shut and hung his head away.

The grief poured out of him in that moment, and they both stayed silent as they let it out. One by one both of their tears joined into the water below and created ripples that intertwined with each other.

After a long, loaded silence, Katsuki pulled Izuku in for a desperate embrace.

He wrapped his arms around Izuku's shaking body and Izuku clung back to him dearly.

They wept softly in the pale blue light, and they didn't let each other go. Katsuki's arms locked around him and his hand threaded through his hair. Izuku felt their hearts press together. He imagined Katsuki slipping away from him and his spirit broke underneath all the regrets he had.

Katsuki guided them down to rest. Izuku struggled to find it in himself to let go, so Katsuki took off his shoes for him. Then he did the same for himself while keeping one arm protectively wrapped around Izuku.

He shifted them over, gliding them delicately. They joined together in the small sleeping bag, fitting together like two perfectly broken glass shards. They laid their heads down together on the duffle bag, facing each other.

The whole time Izuku kept repeating apologies as he clung to Katsuki.

Katsuki stayed silent. He softly stroked Izuku's hair with his shaking hand.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When Izuku awoke, it was to a blaring ringtone close to his ear.

He jolted awake, and so did Katsuki. They shifted in the sleeping bag with tiredness heavy on their eyelids. As they roused, Katsuki's arms were still tightly wrapped around Izuku. He grumbled unhappily as he pulled out his phone.

Katsuki frowned at the bright screen.

He sat upright, muttered an apology, and walked out of the tower to the outside.

Izuku stared after him. His mind was still hazy from sleep, and he tried to catch his bearings. He gazed up to the ceiling of the water tower with sore, puffy eyes. He checked his wrist out of reflex and then groaned at the lack of watch. He really needed to stop doing that. Or get a new watch.

When Katsuki came back inside, he was wearing a tight-lipped frown and fully alert.

"Is it time to head out to the ferry?" Izuku asked, still slightly groggy.

"There's been a change of plans," Katsuki said seriously. He walked over to Izuku with potent urgency and immediately Izuku sat up right. "Something happened on the island with the safe house, it's been compromised."

“Compromised?” Izuku asked. Panic made him very wide awake now. “As in, something bad happened?”

“Yup,” Katsuki said. “We need to get out of here as soon as possible. I tried calling my ex-supervisor directly to see if there was somewhere else we could go—” Katsuki winced and shook his head angrily. “—But that bastard is not answering his phone right now. Like always.”

Izuku’s stomach dropped. He was officially alarmed.

Izuku quickly got out of the sleeping bag and began putting on his shoes.

“So, making a list: as of right now, we can’t go near Tokyo,” Katsuki said as he started rolling up the sleeping bag in a bit of a hurry. “And we need to steer clear of Yokohama too. The estate in Biei is out of the question as well. Both those properties have my legal name attached to them so there’s likely a Yakuza waiting there to see if I walk in.”

“It might be dangerous to pass through Niigata as well,” Izuku murmured, mind racing a mile per minute. He helped Katsuki shove the sleeping bag back in the tiny case it was in. “That’s the Chisaki family’s original home city before they took over Tokyo. There’re deep roots for the Yakuza in that direction.”

“Noted,” Katsuki said diligently. He shoved the sleeping back in his backpack. “Start thinking of other towns we might want to avoid. Because right now, we need to get the fuck out of here *immediately*. I don’t know where we’re going to go but, we’re officially kind of on our own until I hear back from my supervisor.”

“We should go back north,” Izuku quickly suggested. “We can head to that Midnight Sento location that Nana gave me. It’s the bathhouse I was telling you about.”

“Right,” Katsuki agreed quickly. He slung on his jacket and backpack. “Looks like that’s our only option at the moment.”

Izuku pulled his duffle bag over him and zipped up his coat.

They headed out of the water tower swiftly. The morning sun made Izuku’s eyes hurt slightly, and he squinted in reflex. They descended the ladder with added haste until they finally hit the ground. They both walked over to the motorcycle with a quick urgency.

Katsuki put on his helmet quickly and then turned around to put Izuku’s on for him.

Izuku froze a bit, surprised by the affectionate action.

He looked up at Katsuki who was gazing down at him with a stoic expression.

Katsuki looked directly in Izuku’s eyes as he tightened the chin strap. He checked to make sure Izuku’s helmet was on securely with a light tug. In his eyes was contentment, but sitting at the bottom was sorrow.

Katsuki moved to get on his bike and Izuku followed behind him loyally. They slotted together and Izuku's heart began racing quickly. He looked over his shoulder out of paranoia and found nothing but the sunrise.

He gazed at the island off in the distance once more.

Izuku then hesitantly wrapped his arms around Katsuki. He braced himself for Katsuki to stiffen like last time. But he didn't. Instead, Katsuki leaned into the touch and embraced it. He revved the motorcycle's engine and pushed up the kickstand.

"To Midnight Sento we go," Katsuki announced determinedly.

Katsuki sped off towards the road and they embarked on their journey together.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you so so much for reading!! Please let me know what you think below :) writing this story is getting funner and funner! 💜

Chapter 31: Dirge

Chapter Summary

Dirge (Type of song) a somber hymn or lament expressing mourning or grief.

A single name hangs above both Izuku and Katsuki's head.

Chapter Notes

Hellooooo Welcome back to this choo choo train! Thank you guys so much for all your kind comments on the previous chapter! I had a really busy last two weeks and I still need to reply back to everyone but here is the chapter!

Of course thank you the LOML, Luna, for Betaing!! I hope you enjoy :))

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 31 — Dirge

.

.

.

They had been driving for an hour. Rather fast, Izuku noted.

Katsuki was driving like a bat out of hell, swerving between cars like the rules of the road didn't apply to him. Izuku hung on as tight as he could, leaning with the sharp curves they took. Katsuki didn't elaborate on what happened at the safe house. But whatever it was, it must've been urgent enough that it made Katsuki leap to action with an impressive gust of speed.

Now, in record timing, they were in the next city over.

Izuku watched as Katsuki put gas in the tank. He was holding his helmet in one hand while steadying the gas nozzle with the other. His soft blond hair blew with the wind as they stood there. His jacket was zipped up tight, and his eyes—his burning red eyes hadn't left Izuku the whole time.

Katsuki pursed his lips and looked Izuku up and down.

“Let’s stop and grab breakfast,” Katsuki suggested suddenly. “I’ll pay.”

Izuku immediately shook his head and said, “It’s okay, I can make it to Midnight Sento without any food. We need to make it to a safe place before we’re recognized.”

“Izuku, I could feel your stomach rumbling like a goddamn earthquake against me,” Katsuki quipped. He dropped his head to the side entirely unimpressed and raised a brow. “You’re clearly hungry and we still have five hours to go before we get there.”

“Really. It’s fine,” Izuku insisted. “The faster we get there the better. Being hungry doesn’t bother me—”

Izuku choked on his words when Katsuki’s expression twisted into a terrifying scowl.

He tried to backtrack, but it was too late. He realized what he had just touched upon: his famine punishments. When he talked about them last night, Katsuki looked fit enough to hunt down Tomura at that moment and skin him alive.

Without saying a single word, Katsuki took the gas nozzle out of his motorcycle. He placed it back on the hook with a hard slam, making Izuku wish he could eat his words. Katsuki then began to walk up slowly to Izuku. The intense gaze pinned him down where he stood as if it was crafted of knives.

“You’re not going that long without food again *ever*,” Katsuki harshly whispered. “That’s not something you should have ever gotten *used to.*”

“O-Okay,” Izuku agreed.

“But we’ll be quick about it, alright?” Katsuki gently amended. The fierceness in his eyes gave way to sincere concern. “Sorry. I only want to make sure you’re fed. I feel a bit uneasy after hearing about that fucking box. That was really…disturbing.”

“I get it,” Izuku said. He averted his eyes down. “Thank you for, uh, being concerned.”

As if on cue, Izuku’s stomach loudly rumbled in perfect timing.

Katsuki stifled a small laugh and Izuku bashfully smiled. He scratched his cheek and blushed.

“I guess you’re right,” Izuku chuckled. “Breakfast does sound nice.”



The diner they chose for breakfast was very small and private.

There were a handful of people inside, but it was obvious that they were all quickly grabbing a bite to eat before going to work. Several professional men and women in business casual clothes dropped in and out. Others sat down for coffee and began typing on their laptops.

Izuku and Katsuki chose a blue booth in the corner. It was tucked away slightly and close to the backdoor. Katsuki had insisted on this seating in case they needed to make a quick

getaway.

Izuku sat down first and slid towards the wall. He admired the vintage-like photographs hanging up as he put his helmet on the table. There were a lot of pictures of musicians, and some family photos were tacked on top of the soft blue wallpaper.

He patiently waited for Katsuki to sit down across from him.

But instead, Katsuki slid in right next to him. Izuku blinked twice, surprised.

Katsuki sat his helmet down across the table like what he did wasn't abnormal. He turned around, scanned the area, and then lazily put his arm around the seat behind Izuku. He crossed his legs and began to wait for them to be served.

He turned to Izuku, and finally caught his confused gaze. Katsuki raised a brow.

"Why are you looking at me like that?" Katsuki asked.

"Uh, you're sitting on the same side of the booth," Izuku pointed out. "Usually, you sit across the table."

"Ah." Katsuki gazed at Izuku seriously. "It's safer this way. In case someone tries to come at you, I can protect you easier. I usually do this type of technique when I serve as a bodyguard."

"Does this mean I'm officially your client?" Izuku asked, a bit cheekily.

"I guess so, huh?" Katsuki cocked his head, slightly amused. "Who would have thought? After years of being pissy about being put on bodyguard assignments, it came in handy in the end."

Izuku did his best to suppress the smile that bloomed on his face, but he was unable to.

It pushed through, and he beamed at Katsuki. As he did this, Katsuki held his eye contact in a lingering moment of silence. Beautiful scarlet eyes softened, and the contagious smile moved from Izuku's lips to Katsuki's.

They silently regarded at the other.

Katsuki's eyes dropped down to Izuku's lips. He then stared at the hickeys along Izuku's jaw line. A pull of tension caught in the air between them and the endearment in their eyes tangled together into one.

Then, as if Katsuki realized what he was doing, he snapped out of it.

His smile retreated and he awkwardly cleared his throat. His eyes skirted down to the table, and he scratched behind his head. He pulled away his arm that was perched on the booth and neatly folded his hands on the table.

The shift made Izuku's smile drop.

Despite talking through everything, a lingering awkwardness still encompassed them. It stuck to their clothes and imprinted against their skin like a shameful stamp. Because while everything was out in the open, the single fact remained hanging in the air: Izuku did kill Mitsuki.

Izuku was experiencing a new type of guilt. It was more potent than when he killed Hiryu and far heavier than when he murdered Jin, Aoyama or Ibara. This new guilt was sticky and heavy like a ghost was perched on his shoulder soaking him with judgment.

And all this shame pertained to respecting the memory of Mitsuki.

Because here he was: hopelessly in love with her son after he shot a bullet through her.

The more he thought about it, the more and more selfish he felt. It made him feel gross, like he was spitting on her grave and deliberately disrespecting the dead. Because even though there was a small part of him that advised him to leave Katsuki *alone* out of respect, the larger part of him that loved Katsuki *couldn't*.

And that was always their downfall, wasn't it? They were perpetually unable to leave each other alone. Even now, the pull between them that just happened was overwhelming—as if they *needed* to kiss the other.

But they were resisting because of the ghost in the room.

Because of this, Izuku easily thought about the situation from Katsuki's point of view. He wondered if Katsuki was experiencing a similar type of guilt. If he was in Katsuki's shoes, he might feel like he was betraying the memory of his mother by being kind to Izuku.

Izuku turned to face the empty side of the booth. Katsuki did too.

There was a long pause here.

Katsuki's brows furrowed. Izuku glanced down at his hands.

"Are we…okay?" Izuku whispered, unsure.

Katsuki didn't reply right away.

He opened his mouth as if to respond, but he didn't. His words visibly caught in his throat as he stared at Izuku's hands too. He searched the lines and wrinkles like they might hold the answer.

"I'm…processing things. That's all," Katsuki whispered sadly. He seemed painfully torn between two thoughts, yet again. "But yeah. We will be okay."

It didn't go unnoticed to Izuku how that was future tense, not present.

But still, he felt content with that answer. They had a long road to go, both literally and figuratively but they would be okay eventually.

They made it to the small city of Shinonsen without any incident.

The metropolis was secluded and protected by a jagged mountain range that looked as if it was crafted carefully by a sculptor. The tallest peaks were impeccably perfect, pointed high and the lows seemed as if they had been scraped out gently, allowing for a nestle of snow to catch in the pockets.

Inside the mountains were thick rows of tall trees hugging the buildings. Some were changing from green to brown leaves and others were barren.

Immediately upon entering, Izuku felt a shift in the atmosphere.

A sudden fog descended upon them. The cloud was thick, and it made seeing around a bit hard.

But the fog wasn't what offset Izuku, it was the lack of liveliness around them. Even though Shinonsen was a small city, most cities had a buzzing undertone because of the density in population. However, Shinonsen had none of that.

In fact, the mood felt more similar to a graveyard than to a town.

Judging by the way Katsuki slowed down the motorcycle slightly, he felt the shift as well.

They drove slowly, and as they glanced around, they noticed how the taste of solace was in the air. All around them were residents who moved incredibly slow.

Each individual moved as if there were little, tiny rain clouds above their heads. They barely talked or glanced up. All the citizens shuffled around without so much as a single glance to anyone around them.

When Katsuki came to a halt at a red light, they both observed closer.

"Who fucking died?" Katsuki whispered, wearily. "Everyone looks like their dogs got run over by a car."

"Yeah, it's…odd," Izuku agreed. He frowned deeply. "Every single person looks depressed."

Something about all this was off-putting, yet not too terribly concerning. They both put it in the back of their minds and stayed focused on their own predicament.

The light turned green, and they began to head down through the thick fog to Midnight Sento.

Green and red eyes peered up at the large, intimidating building. The roof was pointed in a traditional fashion, and the outside was painted black with trimmings of purple all around it.

Izuku fiddled with his bag as they stood in front of the gates that wrapped all around the perimeter like a fortress.

Katsuki adjusted his backpack and then nodded for Izuku to go in first.

Izuku hiked into the bathhouse with trepidation. When he pushed open the door, a melodic chime announced their presence.

The sweet, lovely smells of lavender, mint, and water welcomed them like a long-awaited hug. The lights inside were a dim, low lit purple and several candles were lit in the windows. There was a hint of humidity in the building as Izuku walked inwards towards the counter.

Katsuki and Izuku both glanced around curiously. They saw some employees shuffle by, and only a single man in a purple towel strolled down the hall.

“It’s basically empty,” Katsuki whispered. “Not a lot of customers?”

Izuku didn’t comment further. Something was bizarre in this town.

“Sorry! One moment!” A lovely voice shouted out from the back.

The sound of boxes tumbling followed and then more apologies. Then out zoomed a blur of black, white, and purple. A tall, beautiful woman who seemed like she could have been related to Nana approached them from behind the counter.

“Sorry about that,” the new woman approaching said with a laugh. “Was doing some inventory during the down time.”

She walked with a confident stride wearing thick, black rimmed glasses that highlighted her stunning sea-blue eyes. On her lips was a charming, subtle smile that was nearly a smirk and her hair was a coarse, thick black that spilled down her back.

She beamed at them, put one of her hands on her hips, and spread out the red fan in her other hand with a sharp whip. Izuku jumped a bit as she coyly hid half of her face and winked at him.

“Ah! New faces. Welcome to Midnight Sento! My name is Kayama Nemuri,” she said sweetly. “What kind of session may I offer you? We’re having a special today in the sauna to accommodate for the terrible news. If you’re here for my other services, all my slots are booked until next month.”

Izuku wanted her to elaborate on that last half a bit. But he stayed focused.

“Uh, we were sent here by Nana actually,” Izuku whispered. “One For All. My name is—”

“—Izuku!” Nemuri nearly shouted.

Her eyes ignited with shimmering sparkles and Izuku was shocked at the sudden onslaught of happiness. Nemuri clasped her hands together tightly then hurried from around the counter.

Izuku staggered backwards as she drew in close. She inspected him closely like a big sister and then sighed.

“Oh, you’re the poor boy she told me about,” She cooed protectively. She glanced Izuku up and down and flexed her hands like she wanted to coddle him, but clearly resisted from doing so. “Ah, you sweet thing. You look like you’ve been through hell and back.”

Right as she was about to say more, she finally noticed Katsuki out of the corner of her eye.

She paused, entirely surprised.

“And who is this?” Nemuri asked carefully.

“Aah, his name is Katsuki,” Izuku answered shyly. He gave a small smile and tilted his head. “He’s, uh, with me and in a similar situation.”

Nemuri cocked her head a bit, growing rightfully cautious. She then said, “Nana didn’t mention that there would be two of you. She very specifically only mentioned that there would be one young man, on the run who needed shelter.”

“It’s a new development since I saw her,” Izuku answered quickly. “He’s trustworthy and won’t say or do anything to jeopardize the situation, I promise.”

Nemuri still seemed apprehensive. “And how do you know each other exactly?”

“Katsuki is my…”

Izuku trailed off as he glanced backwards at the quiet blond behind him.

The various labels piled on his tongue like a traffic jam as he tripped on his words. Husband? Boyfriend? Friend? Bodyguard? Acquaintance? *Ex*?

Both Izuku and Katsuki studied each other for a moment. It was here they realized there was no proper label on what they currently had—even though they had just partaken in a marathon of mind-numbing sex less than two days ago.

At that quiet revelation, Katsuki averted his eyes and scratched behind his head.

Izuku stammered further, floundering entirely. He turned his eyes back towards Nemuri, and then heat stumbled into him deeply when he realized that her eyes now were homed in on the countless hickies all along his neck and jaw.

Izuku cursed himself. “H-He’s my—”

“—We’ve known each other since we were kids,” Katsuki finally spoke up. He didn’t meet Izuku’s gaze as he cleared his throat. “I promise I won’t cause you any type of issues. I want to make sure he’s safe as well.”

“Oh. *I see*,” Nemuri drawled a bit smugly while suppressing a smirk. She put her hands up and spared them both the awkwardness as twin blushes arose on their cheeks. “I take it you

need to lay low as well for a while?"

Katsuki nodded quietly, bowed, and said, "Yes, if you don't mind taking me in as well. I would greatly appreciate it. I have the Yakuza looking for me just like him."

Nemuri gave a low whistle.

"Impressive," Nemuri murmured. "I must give it to the two of you for accomplishing pissing off the Yakuza and then getting out of reach. Well. I guess let's get you two troublemakers settled in. We're slow on business today so I can give you both a tour of your new home for the next two months."

Nemuri pointed to a long hallway with her red fan and a kind smile. She began leading them down the walkway as Izuku and Katsuki trailed behind her.

The two of them exchanged glances and then quickly looked away with pink tinted cheeks.

ᔓᔓᔓ

The bathhouse was impressively large. It was much bigger than it seemed on the outside, and it had already appeared to be a small castle by Izuku's standards.

Every hallway was illuminated by gentle candlelight or lavender colored lanterns. The floorboards were a dark wood that was nearly black, and each bathroom had its own special theme. One was Sakura bloom themed. Another was sunny beach themed, and Izuku's favorite was the one that was painted like it was a galaxy.

"This is the spa section and on the other side of the building are the washrooms," Nemuri explained as she pointed towards the various doors. "There's also a sauna in the back that you two are free to use as well after hours."

Izuku subconsciously kept close to Katsuki as they walked.

As they strolled up and down the various compartments, they encountered numerous employees in purple bathroom uniforms. Some employees smiled at them sweetly and others assessed them up and down to make sure they weren't trouble.

Izuku presumed that this was much more than a bathhouse when he caught sight of one heavily tattooed man. He had three scars running horizontally across his face and a mean enough glare to scare a bear.

Nemuri showed them the outside, and then brought them upstairs through a triple locked door.

It was here that Izuku's sneaking suspiciousness was confirmed. They walked up the steep staircase and soon were in a very lavish looking second floor. It was aligned with multiple rooms and perfect sunlight. Every door had a name on it, and at the end of the hall was one that read 'Mistress Midnight'.

The sound of people laughing echoed from all around while the sounds of various televisions played.

“These are the employee living quarters,” Nemuri explained.

She walked them down to the very last room that read ‘Guest Bedroom number four’ and opened the wooden door. Inside was a small futon, covered in satin black bedding directly in the middle of the floor. There was a tiny bathroom with a shower off to the side and a small vase of yellow daffodils placed next to the window along with a black chair.

All three sets of eyes glanced down at the futon on the floor and the single pillow.

“I only prepared a single bed,” Nemuri said with a flat chuckle. “I can grab an extra pillow, but I don’t have a second futon available right now. Everything else is occupied. I hope you don’t mind this until another futon becomes available.”

“That won’t be necessary. One bed is fine,” Katsuki said.

They shared a small quiet moment. Katsuki shrugged as if it wasn’t something to fret about. Izuku supposed it wasn’t at this point. No matter their lack of label, they had shared a bed so many times now it was basically second nature.

“Well, alright! Perfect then!” Nemuri cheered. “That completes the tour. Dinner will be ready in the grand hall in about an hour and after that you two can do what you want. My only house rules are that you both be inside by 22:30. No trouble making. Don’t bring strangers into the living quarters and don’t disclose to anyone the reason you’re staying here. Is that all clear?”

“Clear,” both Izuku and Katsuki replied.

“Good. Now, you can get settled in and tomorrow you’ll get to work.”

Izuku blinked rapidly and Katsuki cocked his head.

“Wait—work?” Izuku blurted out before he could stop himself.

“Oh yes! I forgot to mention that you’re both employed, congrats!” Nemuri belted out a laugh with her whole chest. She lightly bopped Izuku’s nose with the end of her fan. “This helps me pay for housing, food, and anything else you may need. You start your shifts in the morning with cleaning the baths, floors, and servicing guests. I’ll get you both your uniforms in the morning.”

Izuku smiled and nodded. At least they would have something to fill the time.

“Well go on, get settled in,” Nemuri said to them. She shooed them inside of the room slightly in a hurry. “I’ll see you two in an hour. I need to go back to organizing all the inventory.”

Izuku and Katsuki shuffled inside of the small bedroom. They said thank you with still a tinge of awkwardness from earlier sprayed on them. They accidentally caught each other’s

gazes and blushed once more, making Nemuri give a cheeky smile.

She winked and slid close the door, boxing them in the room uncomfortably tight.

Katsuki sucked in a deep breath. He immediately dropped his bag unceremoniously down to the ground. It hit the floor with a heady thud and Katsuki kicked it into the corner with his boot, clearly exhausted from the drive up. He chucked his helmet into the corner on top of the bag and stripped himself of his coat immediately.

Izuku slowly moved to do the same.

He placed down his duffle bag, helmet, and coat in the opposite corner.

He stared at the small futon on the floor and back at Katsuki.

ᔓᔓᔓ

They uncomfortably waded in the room for a couple of minutes. When they began to choke on the awkwardness, Katsuki suggested they walk around to familiarize themselves with the building. Izuku jumped at the offer, not wanting to be held in that stuffy compact space any longer.

As they strolled, Izuku winced as pain radiated up his spine. He had been fairly good at ignoring it so far, but the ache in his backside was *not* subsiding the way he thought it was going to. He winced a bit as the limp in his walk was exactly the same as when they left the motel in Osaka.

He guessed riding on the motorcycle for so long helped nothing.

Katsuki seemed to notice it too and was discreetly hovering one of his hands in case Izuku fell.

By the time dinner rolled around, the sun was beginning to set earlier than it used to. The sky was a desaturated gray blue and the fog from earlier had thickened up like there was a gathering storm on the way.

They entered the grand hall side by side. Straightaway, the savory smells of food greeted them.

Inside was a large hall of tables, likely for guests. All of which were empty at this time of night, and sitting off in the corner were exactly two dozen people perched at two round tables all in bathhouse uniforms.

At one table was Nemuri. She was sitting closest to the window, munching happily on a sweet treat. All the people at her table were quiet, deep in thought. While no one acknowledged at each other, a large man in a red apron set steaming food down with a serious face.

Nemuri didn't seem to be bothered by the quietness, too far focused on eating her early desserts. She hummed happily as she chewed then turned to face them as they drew closer.

"Welcome! You made it just in time," Nemuri called out. She waved them down and pointed happily to the two seats next to her right side. "The food just finished cooking."

Izuku smiled happily at the warm welcome.

His heart jumped nervously at the kindness as he walked over to one of the empty chairs. He tried to keep a gentle smile graced on his lips as he pushed through his nerves. There were also many people looking at him and Katsuki now. Everyone was smiling, and all eagerly welcomed them with profound kindness that Izuku still struggled to understand.

Izuku chose the chair closest to Nemuri. He quietly said hello to all the other new people. Katsuki followed suit and said hello to the table full of new faces.

As Izuku slid in the seat, pain shot up his backside again.

He stiffened a bit, wincing as he tried to lean his weight off the main source of pain.

No one else around seemed to notice, all too busy with the heaps of food that were being shoveled on to their plates. But when Izuku glanced behind him, he saw Katsuki guiltily looking down at him.

Katsuki pursed his lips to the side. He then proceeded to lean over and tap Nemuri on the shoulder. She perked up and turned to him with a mouth full of food.

"Er, do you happen to have a seat cushion or pillow by any chance?" Katsuki asked in a low whisper so no one else could hear. "He sort of needs one to sit on."

Nemuri nearly choked on her food in surprise and Izuku's eyes went as wide as saucers.

"Of course," Nemuri quickly said as Izuku's face turned a deep, scathing red. "There's some off in the corner right there." She pointed towards the cabinet in the back of the hall.

"Thanks," Katsuki quietly murmured.

Without sparing Izuku a look, he walked over to that side of the room Nemuri had pointed him towards.

As Katsuki did this, Izuku thought his face was going to melt right off from the heat gathering in his cheeks. He so badly wanted to hide his face but resisted so no more attention could be drawn towards him.

When Katsuki came back, he had a light tinge of pink across on his face. In his hands was the world's fluffiest seat cushion. It was light purple with a floral design and golden tassels hanging off the side.

"Lift up," Katsuki commanded simply.

Izuku did so without a fight.

The embarrassment spilled from his cheek down to his neck and chest. The sweltering heat burned inside of him, threatening to consume him whole as Katsuki placed down the seat pillow and fluffed it a bit. When Izuku sat back down, his body practically rejoiced. It was as soft as a cloud.

Izuku visibly relaxed and his shoulders crept down from his ears. Katsuki smiled ever so slightly and took a seat next to him. He assessed Izuku dearly.

“Better?” He asked quietly.

“Better.” Izuku once again couldn’t help but smile shyly. “Thank you.”

“No problem at all, just glad you’re comfortable.”

Their gazes caught for a second and tender smiles were exchanged between them.

“Who are these two new additions?” Someone finally asked.

Izuku turned to see the owner of the velvety voice. It was a tall woman with short blonde hair chopped off at her ears. She had striking, gray-blue eyes that matched the way the sky was outside the window.

“I’m so happy you asked,” Nemuri replied cheerily. She slyly smiled at the blonde woman and then gleefully gestured beside her. “Everyone! This is Izuku and Katsuki. They’re a favor I’m fulfilling for a good friend of mine. They’re going to be staying with us for a while, so everyone be nice to them and don’t be too nosy. Give them their space while they’re here.”

The small warning tacked at the end seemed to make everyone nod in understanding.

“So nice to meet you both, I’m Ryuko,” the blonde woman said. She then pointed beside her at another blonde woman who had long hair that stopped at her waist. “This is my cousin, Takeyama. The big guy who is putting food on everyone’s plate is Sekijiro. He’s the house chef.”

Izuku smiled as Sekijiro filled his bowl up with savory noodles and vegetables.

Nemuri leaned in and whispered only for Izuku to hear, “Be sure to tell Sekijiro you like his cooking later, it’ll make him super happy. He’s been working on this broth all month.”

Izuku giggled a bit and smiled at Nemuri. He waved at everyone and said, “nice to meet you all.”

“Same,” Katsuki echoed. “Thank you for allowing us to crash here for a while.”

“It’s an open house really,” Ryuko explained. “Nemuri has done a great job at providing a perfect work-living situation for those who need it. It’s always a pleasure to see new faces. We have so many people coming in and out of here.”

Izuku waited for more explanation, but nothing came.

Everyone began eating quietly the second Sekijiro sat down. On the chef's face was an extremely dejected pain that mirrored across everyone.

Even Nemuri seemed to have this same type of sadness weaved in and out of her eyes. Hers was a bit more well-hidden as she tried to mask it behind over-enthusiastic smiles. But it showed through like true sadness always does.

"What's up with all the long faces around here?" Katsuki asked abruptly.

Everyone's eyes snapped up to look at them and Izuku resisted elbowing him in the side.

"Ah. Our mayor's daughter passed away," Nemuri explained sadly. "Sorry for the glum mood. Was it that obvious?"

"Just a bit," Izuku whispered. "I'm sorry to hear about her passing."

"It's okay," Nemuri muttered. "You have nothing to be sorry for. But everyone around here is going to be a bit gloomy for the next week or so I imagine."

"Did you all know her well?" Katsuki asked curiously as he ate.

"Yes," Sekijiro answered. The happiness in his eyes faded away like a glimmering star behind a cloud. "She was like the sun around here because she was this huge socialite. Everyone knew her and she would throw these grand fabulous parties for free and let people come and mingle."

"She was also preparing to be the next mayor," Ryuko added with tight lips. "We were all looking forward to it because she basically knew everyone by name individually. It made sense for her to be the next in line. She finally made this foggy city feel like a community."

Izuku noted how Ryuko's cousin, Takeyama, didn't say anything.

There was a distant faraway gaze in Takeyama's eyes as she pushed around the food on her plate.

"That's so sad," Izuku muttered. "I'm sorry for all of your losses."

"Thank you, Izuku," Nemuri said. She tried her best to smile and put up the happy-go-lucky persona she had carefully curated. But Izuku could see it wasn't sticking this time as much. "I guess everyone is just finding it tough to adjust without her because it happened so suddenly."

"If you don't mind me asking, how did she pass?" Izuku probed carefully, curiosity in bloom.

"It was a car accident," Nemuri answered gravely. "Car crash. The fog here gets so thick sometimes that it is hard to see. It was so heavy the day she was coming back from work, and

it caused someone to veer into the opposite lane. They had a head on collision at high-speed leaving three injured, one dead."

The sound of skidding tires reverberated in Izuku's head. He unfortunately imagined everything.

"That's horrible," Katsuki muttered. "I'm really sorry you all are experiencing that."

"At the end of the week her father is hosting an impromptu lantern festival to honor her," Nemuri said. "It's something she would've liked, to bring everyone in the city together one more time. But she wouldn't want it to be all about her since her parties never were. Her gatherings were always honoring other people. So, this festival will be in her ways. Everyone attending is allowed to remember the memory of their own loved ones who have passed."

Both Izuku and Katsuki grew quiet.

A mountain of names appeared before Izuku.

He could visualize all the faces of his fallen siblings in front of him. They all wore pale, grisly expressions and were maimed in the very way he killed them. Aoyama's neck was nearly in two, while Ibara's was full of holes. Jin's skull was nearly blown open from a gunshot. And Hiryu was there, with the bullet hole between his eyes.

But standing in front of them was Mitsuki.

No wounds. No blood. She was as beautiful as the day she was killed.

Her name hung over both of their heads.

The silence between them became tangible again, and Izuku didn't dare look over to Katsuki. Guilt trickled down his sides. He hung his head, allowing his bangs to cover his eyes, and slowly began eating.

"She sounds like she was incredibly thoughtful," Katsuki whispered in a taut tone. Izuku nearly winced at the pain inside of it. "Her father must've known her very well to know this is something she would like."

"They were incredibly close," Nemuri said sadly. "Truly an admirable father-daughter bond."

Not another word was really said after that. Nemuri grew quiet. Ryuko distantly gazed out the window. Takeyama didn't touch her food. Sekijiro did his best to keep people's plates stacked with vegetables while wearing a dejected gaze.

They all sat there, suspended in grief.

ᔓᔓᔓ

As he showered that night, Izuku wondered if grief was a lack of gravity at its core.

People were anchors in each other's lives in some way, keeping each other tethered to reality. Some people even kept others connected to this earth. It wasn't uncommon that when someone died, sometimes their loved one simply couldn't go on without them. Some pass directly behind the person they loved. Or some spiraled into madness much like that violinist they used to know.

Izuku imagined all the people someone loved as anchors.

The weight of the anchor depended on the depth of the love they held for them. The more, the heavier. One by one, if the rope to these anchors is cut, then that would leave someone floating. They would be suspended in air—all by themselves mourning the loss of the ones who kept them grounded.

That's what this town felt like.

They had lost their anchor, and now, they were suspended in grief.

That's what Katsuki seemed like as well.

He lost his anchor five years ago, and he seemed suspended in grief ever since. Never moving on. Never processing it. To Izuku, Katsuki's grief over his mother remained so stagnant because his love for her was mixed up in so many other, sometimes conflicting, emotions.

Katsuki felt an abundance of responsibility for her yet suffered from her neglect. He had to push down his own needs day after day to cater to hers. He was a devoted son so much that he didn't have any other identity of his own outside of her. And because of that, she really was one of the only things keeping Katsuki tethered to reality.

Izuku turned off the shower and proceeded to get out. He dried his body thoroughly, re-bandaged his wounds, and changed into the one pair of pajamas Nana had packed for him.

When he opened the door, he got an earful of Katsuki on the phone.

"Sero, I don't give a *shit* if he's on vacation, you push me through to him right *now*," Katsuki hissed with his back turned to Izuku. "Tell him it's an emergency. Like a really big emergency involving the *Yakuza*. I fucked up big time. Please. Get him to call me."

Katsuki was standing only in his black boxers in the middle of the room. He had already showered and then informed Izuku he didn't exactly bring pajamas. So, he was going to be sleeping in his underwear.

Izuku moved to the futon and Katsuki glanced over his shoulder.

They held eye contact for a moment of silence. Izuku could see a soft, weary feeling pouring through those lovely red eyes. The person on the other end of the phone audibly sighed and said something Izuku couldn't hear.

Katsuki's eyes sparked and he began nodding eagerly.

“Okay,” Katsuki agreed quickly. “Thank you, Sero. Really, I owe you one. I’ll be waiting for his call.”

Katsuki said his goodbyes and hung up. He walked over to the nightstand and plugged in the charger to his black phone. He shuffled over to the futon as well and when Izuku got in, he was surprised to feel several more comforters laid down on top of the futon.

“I, uh, asked Nemuri for extra padding while you were in the shower,” Katsuki murmured. “Does it help at all?”

Izuku blushed the color of candy. He got into the covers and was pleasantly surprised at how cushioned the futon was. It was better than a cloud, it was like floating on air. He didn’t feel any ache in his legs and the soft surface was like a giant Band-Aid.

He smiled at Katsuki as he put his head down.

“It does help a lot,” Izuku admitted. “I can barely feel anything. Thank you again for taking care of me.”

Katsuki fiddled with his fingers slightly as he studied Izuku. He forcefully smiled and said, “of course.”

Katsuki walked across the room and turned off the lights. The pale moonlight skated across his skin, and Izuku looked at the fresh bandage wrapped around Katsuki’s gunshot wound. He turned to Izuku then and glanced at the sliver of space next to him.

Izuku scooted over the best he could, and Katsuki joined him in the bundle of comforters.

Their arms pressed flush against each other.

The warmth was like a blazing fire. Izuku always adored the way Katsuki ran hot, and even now, he wished he could cuddle into it more. He wondered if that would be weird, as they still hadn’t discussed anything.

They both laid on their backs looking up at the ceiling, unsure of what exactly to do. Izuku twirled his thumbs, trying to think of something to talk about. But when he racked his brain, he found nothing but Mitsuki staring back at him. His heart dropped instantly.

Izuku turned away to hide his pained expression.

“Goodnight, Katsuki.”

“…Goodnight, Izuku.”



In the middle of the night, Izuku was stirred awake by an arm wrapping around his waist.

It was familiar and he could tell the texture of the skin purely from memory at this point. He leaned into it through his sleepy haze and snuggled closer on the pillow automatically. He

turned his body inwards, facing the heat that was radiating against him.

When he fluttered his eyes open, his heart skipped a beat.

Katsuki was awake, staring at him with lost eyes.

He was floating. Without gravity.

He looked so sad as he shuffled in more. He dragged Izuku closer, hooking his arms all around Izuku's body. Their legs tangled and Katsuki shifted so that Izuku was locked in. The closer he got, the more gravity seemed to return to his eyes. Their noses brushed for a moment, and Katsuki hesitantly ran a hand through Izuku's hair.

They looked at each other wordlessly in the dark.

Then Katsuki drew closer. He rested their foreheads together and closed his eyes once more. Izuku closed his eyes too, and he wrapped his arms around Katsuki's body. The heat sunk into him, and he felt like he could sleep peacefully again.

It was here Izuku felt his heart tug. It pulled in the direction of Katsuki fiercely, making him nuzzle in closer. Katsuki gripped him lovingly, as if afraid to let go.

This was the night Izuku realized Katsuki was his only anchor. He was more than that, really.

Katsuki was his gravity.

ᔓᔓᔓ

They were put to work bright and early. Nemuri came pounding on their door at exactly 7:00 in the morning with their uniforms. Izuku's was a size too big, and Katsuki's was a smidge too small for him.

She showed them the room they oversaw cleaning before guests came in today, and it ironically was the beach room. Fake plastic trees were stationed everywhere, halfway blown up and the walls were painted pink and sea-form green.

It reminded Izuku of Okinawa in a way. He suddenly deeply missed that trip, and how different everything had been back then. He looked to his side to see Katsuki staring blankly at the painting of the beach on the wall. He seemed dejected as well.

When they were handed the bucket and scrub, Nemuri patted them on the back cheerfully.

"You boys have fun!" She said in a sing-song voice. "Make sure to make it shine by nine!"

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku scrubbed the tile of the beach room with all his best efforts.

He tried his greatest to put all his strength in his motions until he saw the concrete between the tiles turn from gray to white. The work was surprisingly rewarding and gave him something to keep his mind occupied.

Curiously, Izuku looked across the way.

On the other side of the room underneath one of the fake plastic palm trees was Katsuki. He was squatting as he scrubbed with the deepest frown Izuku had ever seen on him. He glanced up and did a small double take at Izuku, who was gazing at him unabashed.

Katsuki awkwardly waved.

Izuku felt that pull in his heart again.

He blushed a bit and stood up. He grabbed his bucket and walked over to squat beside Katsuki. He began scrubbing next to him. They exchanged tiny, knowing stares, and quietly worked next to each other, side by side for the next hour.

About halfway through their cleaning, Izuku wiped his brow from sweat. These floors were far dirtier than he ever imagined. He checked the heart shaped clock on the wall and saw they had about an hour left. Izuku stood up to grab a cup of water.

But when he tried to step forward, he slipped backwards. He gasped when his heel connected with a wet bar of soap on the slippery tile.

Izuku's eyes widened, Katsuki's did too.

Izuku twisted easily to catch himself. He had good reflexes and tripping wasn't a big deal.

But instead of hitting the floor, he suddenly slammed into Katsuki who leapt into action to catch him. Their heads knocked together with an agonizing slam, and both yelled in pain. They went tumbling backwards into the blow-up palm tree behind them and it fell on them with a humorous bounce.

Izuku opened his eyes as Katsuki hissed.

Izuku winced as he pulled back. He tried to roll from off top of Katsuki but was locked in place by a protective hold.

"Holy *fuck*." Katsuki let out a groan of pain. "Why the hell is your head so *hard*?"

"My brother always said I have a thick skull," Izuku grumbled as he rubbed his head. "Not in a good way though."

"He was right. I think I'm seeing stars. Remind me never to be head-butted by you."

"Same for you, your head felt like a *rock*. Why would you jump in the way like that?"

Katsuki cringed as he finally opened his eyes. "I was afraid you were going to hurt yourself. I was trying to catch you but *clearly* that failed."

“But I have good reflexes, you know that.”

“I forgot for a moment.”

“You forgot I’m a trained *assassin*?”

Katsuki scoffed. He tried to quell a laugh, but it slipped past his lips.

“Ya, I guess I did forget, huh?” Katsuki chuckled. He laughed more, and it built up. He smirked a bit and shook his head. “Maybe you have to shoot me again to remind me. I’m so goddamn stupid sometimes.”

He kept laughing and soon Izuku joined in. Izuku sat up on Katsuki’s lap and Katsuki propped himself up with his elbows. With an amused smirk, the handsome blonde slapped the plastic palm tree away when it tickled his shoulders.

“You were just trying to protect me,” Izuku giggled. “Not the worst thing in the world.”

“Tell that to the concussions that we just probably gave each other.”

The laughter in the air was beautiful.

It mingled with a dancing melody as Katsuki doubled down. He threw his head back and snorted as Izuku tried to slap a hand over his own mouth. Naturally, Katsuki sat up more, and Izuku shifted to get off him, but Katsuki kept him seated.

Firm hands settled on his waist and held him in place as Katsuki leaned up all the way. He gazed down at Izuku lovingly, and the adoration was so potent in the moment as they laughed together.

Izuku tilted his head.

He was entirely enamored with how handsome Katsuki was with a grin on his face. He glowed like this, teeth on display and smile lines deeply dented. Izuku realized he hadn’t seen Katsuki this chock-full of happiness in nearly a month.

He missed this.

Izuku didn’t think much as he pushed a hair out of Katsuki’s face. But the second his fingers grazed Katsuki’s skin, it was like zapping all the joy out of the moment.

Katsuki stopped laughing.

His face sobered up immediately. He moved his hands off Izuku’s waist like he was being burned and leaned back.

They stared at each other and all the magic that had gathered died. Katsuki cleared his throat and Izuku’s heart nearly broke. He moved off Katsuki’s lap and hugged his arm. He hung his head away when he once more could feel the eyes of Mitsuki staring at them.

“You’re…having a difficult time being around me,” Izuku whispered, finally breaking the barrier on the unspoken issue between them. “Sorry. I’ll try to keep my distance.”

Katsuki whipped his head up, eyes wide. “Izuku, no—”

“I get it.” Izuku spoke over him. He shook his head, not wanting to be coddled. “I-I’m having a hard time too. But I imagine you more so, rightfully, since she was your mom. I don’t blame you at all, really. If it gets too hard, I can leave the room. Or we cannot speak for a while to ease the hurt—”

“—Izuku, it’s not that.”

Katsuki shifted to sit across from Izuku. He sagged his shoulders and struggled to make eye contact yet again. Izuku bit his lip and tugged at his wrists.

“You feel like loving me would be a betrayal to her, right?” Izuku whispered.

Katsuki didn’t say anything. But he didn’t have to, his silence and the pain that ran across his eyes was enough.

He turned his head away and quietly nodded.

Izuku hung his head. “I feel that way too, honestly. I have this overwhelming guilt for killing her and now here I am, in love with her son. I feel…selfish. And I don’t want to be selfish.”

“Me either,” Katsuki confessed with a wobbly voice.

Silence.

It stretched on, wrapping them both in it. Izuku looked around the room, suddenly feeling angry at the pink walls they were trapped in. How did they always wind up surrounded by the opposite of what they were feeling?

“But…the issue I have isn’t with you, specifically,” Katsuki muttered suddenly. “I’ve been thinking about a lot of things since the night at the water tower.”

Izuku lifted his head up. They made eye contact and Katsuki dropped his head lower between his shoulders.

“What type of things have you been thinking about?” Izuku dared to ask.

“Like how I’ve killed people’s parents too.”

Izuku’s eyes softened when he realized where Katsuki’s head was.

“My very first kill, he was a father,” Katsuki admitted quietly. “I orphaned his daughter according to my ex-supervisor. Then my very first mark, he was also a father. I had accidentally shot him right in front of his *very* young son, who was in the room. I didn’t even see the kid standing there until I checked through my lens after.”

Izuku imagined a small child leaning over the limp body of his father.

“I’m sure there’s more,” Katsuki whispered in agony. “I’m responsible for just as many parentless people in the world as you probably are. Because when I killed that guy when I was thirteen, I didn’t stop and consider if he had a family. All I knew is that it was sink or swim. Kill or be killed.”

“You walked in on that man with a gun to your mother’s head,” Izuku muttered. “There was no time to consider if he had a family, Katsuki.”

“Exactly,” Katsuki agreed. “And you had a machete to your throat when you pulled the trigger and killed my mother. It was killed or be killed then too because a mark is a mark, right? How can I blame you without being a hypocrite? But…I do feel guilty. Because while all those people were parents, my mother was still *my* mother. And my mother was *spiteful*.”

Katsuki ran his head through his hair and shook his head.

“She held onto grudges like a goddamn leech,” Katsuki spat. “She’s mainly where I get my attitude from—*but*. She also was a believer in new beginnings. She never thought it was too late to start over. She did it countless times. She lived more lives than I ever knew, and she always was prepared to take a new clean slate because she believed it was never too late.”

She sounded more and more lovely every time Katsuki described her.

“I’m so sorry,” Izuku whispered. “I know there’s no amount of sorrys that can heal what you’re feeling, b-but I don’t think I can ever express how truly sorry I am.”

“I know,” Katsuki whispered somberly. “I’m sorry too. I just wish I could talk to her. I want to know what she would want me to do in this situation if that makes sense. I keep trying to figure out what she would say, or what advice she would give to make this guilt easier—But…I don’t know. I can’t tell if she would choose spite or new beginnings.”

Tears welled in both of their eyes, and they looked at each other.

They didn’t move as they remained suspended in their grief.

Izuku thought about all that happened. He unwillingly found himself piled under all the guilt he was feeling. It was all too much and too wide. Like an ocean that had dried up and he needed to cross it to see the other side.

But all he could find was barren land that stretched so endlessly.

ᔓᔓᔓ

The next week passed with enough stale awkwardness that Izuku could potentially bottle it up and sell it.

During this time, Izuku wordlessly would watch as Katsuki checked his black phone repeatedly. He waited for the call that never came and Izuku was beginning to grow a bit

worried. He hoped nothing happened to Katsuki's ex-supervisor.

They put their full heart into working to pass the time. There were little customers, however. Just like Nemuri said there would be. And the lack of business meant more time alone with each other.

As a result, Izuku and Katsuki did a strange shuffle around the other while still sharing a bed. Every night it was like they indulged in the guilty pleasure of each other's warmth, and in the morning, it seemed as if they wanted to wash it off.

Izuku didn't say much as this happened, and neither did Katsuki.

The pensive air around them was tangible enough that the other employees could practically see Mitsuki herself standing between them, keeping them apart.

When the night of the festival came, Izuku debated on going.

It seemed a bit odd for him to attend. Everyone he would light a lantern for, he killed, and he was sure that would earn him some rightful hauntings in the long run. He originally was going to stay in his room, or maybe re-clean the beach room, but Nemuri insisted that they *both* go.

"It's what she would have wanted," Nemuri said, referring to the woman who the festival was for. "I even got you guys the right size kimonos. We'll all be matching a bit, isn't that cute?"

Izuku didn't want to be rude and decline their host.

So here he was, putting on a purple, black and red kimono that matched Katsuki's. He tightened the sash on it and put the black haori over his shoulders.

Katsuki did the same, and there was an evident pensiveness tucked away on the back of his mind.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When they arrived at the festival it was haunting in a beautiful way.

Hundreds, if not thousands, of people were gathered all around holding up lanterns. Each lantern in a person's hand mimicked a burning, lost soul. The tall buildings all around them were dimmed, as if they were giants closing their eyes in respect for the dead. The fog had thickened up, letting only what was near to be visible.

Nemuri led them to the front of the festival. There were a large crowd of people gathered, being handed lanterns and matches. Everyone was lighting a flame, and then heading towards the town square.

All the employees of the bathhouse grabbed a lantern and inscribed a loved one's name on the paper material.

Izuku stepped forward, but stopped when Katsuki didn't follow.

He turned back. Katsuki was standing there, as if frozen in time. He looked despondent as he glanced around at the many people all holding hands.

Woefully scarlet eyes looked towards Izuku.

"Should I get one?" Katsuki asked.

Izuku was surprised he was even being consulted.

He could see there was an invisible rope holding Katsuki back. But in the quiet part of Izuku's mind, he knew Katsuki needed something like this. This would be a healthy outlet to begin the course of processing his mother's death.

Izuku nodded, well assured. "I think you should."

Katsuki took his advice. He stepped forward in the line and took a lantern from off the table. The wind blew as he did this, and there was the feeling of a fog of ghosts hovering all over them. Katsuki looked down at the unlit lantern and then picked up the sharpie.

With an unsteady hand, Katsuki transcribed his mother's name.

Izuku resisted the urge to hold his hand.

Katsuki grabbed a match and together they walked into the crowd. They met up with the rest of the group from the bathhouse and all together they marched towards the town square.

When they arrived, there was an older man with thick silver hair standing on a stage. He was in front of a podium, gazing across the sea of citizens with the bluest gaze Izuku had ever seen. It looked troubled, and mournful beyond his years.

"That's the mayor," Sekijiro whispered to Izuku.

Izuku nodded in understanding. Now it all made sense.

When the tribute started, Izuku's heart clenched as he gazed around at all the people holding lanterns. He was one of the few who weren't. He wondered what the stories were in this dense crowd. Who lost someone and how? Were some of the people who Katsuki and Izuku affected in this crowd amongst them?

Izuku grimly pondered on the last thought. His eyes shifted to look down at the unlit lantern in Katsuki's hands.

The mayor gave a beautiful speech. It was full of love, hope, and a perfect tribute to his daughter who shined as bright as a star. Everyone around them was brought to tears, and it made both Izuku and Katsuki nearly cry as well.

The mayor then lit his lantern.

Like a domino effect, suddenly all the lanterns in the crowd began to light up. The space began to illuminate with yellow light in the dense fog. A clear visual of the rows and rows of people all gathered was revealed.

Katsuki exhaled shakily. He tried to light his lantern with the match. He failed the first three times, and Izuku could see the growing frustration begin to build. Katsuki wearily glanced around at all the new flames and his fingers began shaking.

Izuku stepped forward quickly. He held his hands out as a shield against the vicious wind over the small wick.

Katsuki looked up at him, surprised but thankful. His eyes softened as he lit the lantern without issue. Together they protected the flame as Katsuki safeguarded it with his own hand now. Izuku moved away and caught Nemuri looking at them both gently.

The mayor then stepped down and held up his lantern.

The elder man led the way with his head held high. He walked through the fog that surrounded them towards the river. Everyone began following, and soon they found themselves up where the river connected to the mountain. It flowed down from the beautiful mountain and traveled straight into the ocean.

Everyone began to spread out on either side of the long stream.

The fog rolled over the water like a whisper.

The mayor stepped forward first. From his position at the top of the river, he let go of the lantern holding his daughter's memory. He watched her leave, and there was something beautiful about the action. He observed with eyes full of love, not grief, as she drifted away.

One by one, everyone began to let their lanterns go as hers passed.

By the time her lantern made it to where Izuku and Katsuki were, it was a full collection of memories drifting by them. Hundreds of names from people neither of them knew, but they still felt bonded to. Izuku glanced around, and found everyone sharing hugs and sad, gentle smiles. The whole crowd was bonded in the one universal human experience: loss.

All the employees from the bathhouse began to let their lanterns go.

Soon everyone around them did the same.

They watched as person after person placed down a lantern, letting it go into the narrow stream. The beautiful red and yellow lights tangled with each other and mingled into the crowd.

Izuku noted how Katsuki held on to the lantern with his mother's name tightly. His fingers were trembling slightly, as if afraid to let go. The look in his eyes was close to a lost boy all alone in the crowd. He observed people do what he couldn't.

Nemuri then turned to Katsuki and placed a kind hand on his shoulder.

“Take your time,” she said gently. “We’re all going to go back to the bathhouse now. When you’re ready, head home. No curfew tonight.”

Katsuki nodded stiffly. Nemuri gave Izuku a knowing glance and Izuku mouthed ‘thank you’ to her.

The bathhouse employees left them there, and soon the crowd began to thin out.

Katsuki held the lantern close to his chest and Izuku didn’t push him.

They began to walk down the river in the night air side by side, watching all the lanterns light up the scene. When they came down to the end of the river near the ocean, they finally stopped. Katsuki stared out at the endless, dark horizon that was coated in fog.

Izuku counted each lantern in his head as their lights disappeared into the fog to the other side.

“Why did it have to be you?” Katsuki muttered. “Out of all people, why you?”

Izuku wanted to blame fate.

But he was truly questioning the concept of fate lately.

“I don’t know,” Izuku said instead. “I wish it wasn’t.”

“Me too,” Katsuki whispered.

Katsuki had been right about consequences versus fate. So far, all Izuku has done is face the consequences of his bloodied actions. He watched as Katsuki’s dejected eyes drowned more in his ocean of sadness. He lowered his head as he squatted down on the patch of grass next to the river.

Izuku joined him wordlessly, leaving enough room for the ghost of Mitsuki between them.

Katsuki painfully looked at the lantern in his hands. The yellow light illuminated his crestfallen face, making him appear younger than he was. A line of countless lanterns passed them by on the river. One by one they watched them go while the one in Katsuki’s hand stayed rooted in place.

Katsuki turned to Izuku.

“But even if it wasn’t you, another Viper eventually would’ve killed her, right?” He whispered.

Izuku flashed back to that night.

He remembered Himiko taking aim, and then stopping her.

“…Yes.” Izuku sadly admitted.

“And if I didn’t kill that guy when I was thirteen, he would’ve killed her.” Katsuki kept going, spiraling in his own endless void of thoughts. “And if I didn’t stop Aizawa, *he* would’ve killed her—and who knows who else.”

Katsuki clutched the lantern tighter in his hands as he began trembling.

“Y’know, I asked her once who would want her killed for owing a debt and she couldn’t even come up with a list. She said it could be *anyone*. Somehow, someone always would have likely killed her because she always had her past chasing her.”

Izuku pinched his brow together. “What type of past did she have?”

“That’s the thing, I don’t *know*.” Katsuki’s voice broke on the last word. “I will never know. That will always be an open ending for me because I realize I-I didn’t know my mom very well. But all I did know was that her gambling addiction put her in so much shit.”

Katsuki clenched his jaw.

“I still blame Chisaki for taking advantage of someone with an addiction. But I have to blame her a bit too, don’t I? All this time I thought she died because of a mistake *I* made—” Katsuki choked as he sucked in his lips. “When really, she died because it was a mistake she made. All this time, it had nothing to do with me.”

Katsuki shook his head and closed his eyes.

Izuku stayed silent and let Katsuki work through all the pain inside of him.

“She could never stay away from the things that put her in trouble,” Katsuki mournfully admitted. “No matter how much I wanted her to, she was always doomed from the start. And I think even my father knew that. It’s why his dying wish to a *five year old* was to take care of his mother. He knew she wouldn’t have been able to survive on her own—because her worst enemy was herself. B-But I couldn’t save her in the end…no matter how much we both loved each other.”

Katsuki looked down at the lantern in front of him like it was a puzzle.

The more he gazed at the flickering light, it seemed like the pieces inside of his head lined up more and more.

“My love for her was never enough and that always made me feel like *I* was never enough,” Katsuki whispered. “I cried, yelled and I screamed at her to be better. But she wasn’t capable. All I wanted was for her to live and see how much potential she had. She was the center of my world for so long and when she passed, I had no clue what to do with myself. I had never __”

Katsuki stopped at the words.

Izuku’s eyes grew full of pity.

He recalled when they first arrived at the estate in Biei. Katsuki back then had seemed so lost, like he was in his own body for the first time. He had never relaxed or taken the time to consider himself for more than a brief second.

“I had never thought of putting myself first,” Katsuki admitted. “I sacrificed my grades in school for her. I took that job *for* her. I didn’t even have time to go out and make friends outside of work. I did all I could to take care of us—because that was all I ever knew. Just… take care of mom and be a good, grateful son.”

A moment of silence.

Katsuki’s face dropped as if a revelation dawned on him.

“…And that always kept me away from happiness because I was so preoccupied with centering her. Didn’t it?” Katsuki whispered.

Izuku wanted to agree.

He saw so much of himself in Katsuki. They were a mirror of each other with vastly different shackles chaining them to a life neither of them chose. But he didn’t say anything. He wanted Katsuki to keep going and work through what he was feeling.

He shifted closer and hugged his arms around Katsuki’s shoulders as a silent form of support.

Katsuki leaned his head against Izuku’s as he continued to talk through his pain.

“Y’know, I never had hobbies because I was too worried over her,” Katsuki whispered. “I worked too much to enjoy life because I needed to pay for two of everything. Part of the reason I gave up on ever finding a relationship was because I felt like I wouldn’t find the time. My whole life was about her—and even now, it somehow still is.”

Izuku hugged Katsuki tighter as his own tears began to spill down.

“I know she loved me to the full capacity she was able to, and I loved her too. I always will—but even now in a twisted way, she’s *still* blocking me from happiness. My grief over her is keeping me away from you. I think…I think if I ever want real happiness, I need to stop centering her. Don’t I?”

“I can’t tell you how to live your life, Katsuki,” Izuku mournfully whispered. “You have to do what you think is right.”

“I know. But the happiest I ever was in my life was with you at the estate,” Katsuki confessed. “It was the first time I wasn’t focusing on her in my *whole* life. I thought it was retirement making me happy, but it was you.”

He lifted his head and pulled away from the embrace.

He looked at Izuku like he was the only anchor left in his life.

“I want to be happy, Izuku,” Katsuki said. A tear rolled down his cheek. “Do you think I’m capable of it?”

“I do.” Izuku wiped away the tear tenderly. “I know you’re capable of it.”

Izuku looked down at Katsuki’s trembling hands holding the lantern. It threatened to fall at that moment.

He scooted in closer.

Delicately, Izuku placed his hands over Katsuki’s juddering fingers. The roughness of his skin stood out as all the callouses from his years shook underneath Izuku’s touch. Slowly, Katsuki stopped trembling with help. Their fingers wove together on the lantern.

Katsuki stared across from Izuku lovingly. Izuku stared back at him too.

They didn’t shy away from it this time and embraced the love they had for each other at that moment.

It felt like there were arms around them both, hugging them like a third presence was with them. They both glanced down at the lantern. They gave each other a silent, loaded gaze and both of their hearts began hammering in tandem. Katsuki bowed at the same time Izuku did and together, they gently put the lantern in the water.

They sat there quietly, watching it go with the others downstream.

It floated away into the ocean, disappearing to the other side of the fog.



Later that night, Izuku found himself dreaming.

He usually didn’t have such vivid dreams, but for the first time in his life, he dreamt in rich color he knew he would remember it when he woke up.

He was standing alone in shallow water at sunset. All around him was fog, but the sky was a lovely, warm shade of pink. Like the color of blush, or roses. Maybe even carnations. The whole atmosphere glowed like someone purposefully painted the scene with every shade of pink they could think of.

He tried to walk around and discovered he was wading through a shallow pool or water that reached his ankles. It was chilling, yet warm. He looked up and somewhere in the fog he could see a blinking, yellow light in the distance.

A heat rolled from it, and Izuku found himself pulled to it like a moth to a funeral pyre.

He walked forward, following the blinking light. The closer he got, the warmer his skin became. He trudged forward, squinting through the haze.

When he finally arrived at the glowing light, it morphed.

The small light shifted into a long line and then spread. Izuku shielded his eyes from the blinding glow that took over him, and when he looked forward again there was Mitsuki.

She was glowing in a radiating warmth as charming as her smirk.

Izuku felt his heart stop.

He dropped to his knees in the water and lowered his head immediately. Even in a dream, he didn't feel like he deserved to look straight at her. He kept his head down and began muttering a sleuth of apologies. Then a warm hand touched him.

She brushed his hair and squatted down in front of him. A gentle finger lifted his chin and forced him to look into her overwhelming radiance. Her dream version had taken the form of the only picture Izuku had seen of her.

In her hair were petals of pink carnations and the smell of flowers wafted off her.

"If you want to make it up to me, I think I know what you can do," she whispered.

Her voice carried like a breeze. Gentle, powerful, and moved Izuku to tears.

"What is it?" Izuku asked desperately. "I-I'll do anything."

"Take good care of him for me," She whispered.

If hearts could melt, Izuku's would do so right there. He looked into her eyes and saw all the love she had for Katsuki flash inside of them.

"I can do that," Izuku promised. "I *will* do that for you."

Mitsuki smiled. She chuckled in the same way Katsuki always did. Her sharp, scarlet eyes gazed at him approvingly as she tilted her head sadly. In the reflection of her eyes, Izuku saw the movie of her and Katsuki's life. He saw her hold him as a baby, raise him as a toddler and then spend time with him as a teenager. She loved him as purely as she could and it transcended through her.

"You probably could do a better job than I ever could taking care of him," Mitsuki said a bit woefully. "Just make sure my brat is happy. And try to get him to relax, okay? He needs it. He's too young to act this old."

"I'll do the best I can," Izuku said with a small smile.

"Good. Now, I think it's time to wake up. He's waiting for you."

ɯɯɯ

Izuku startled awake with a jolt.

He lightly gasped as his eyes shot open, and he rapidly blinked away the haze of sleep that was wrapped around his mind. He glanced around the room he was in, completely thrown off

from the dream. He stared and stared at the wall until he realized where he was.

Izuku sighed tiredly and grabbed his head.

What a strange dream, he thought offhandedly. But despite knowing it was just a dream, he couldn't help but feel oddly content about what was said.

"*Take good care of him*," the phrase echoed in his head.

Izuku gradually sat up on the futon and rubbed his eyes. He looked over to where Katsuki should be—only to find it empty.

He glanced up, and there was the missing blond. He was sitting in the chair that was by the window. The soft sunlight glittered into the room and spilled across his high cheekbones like a painting. His eyes were turned down, regarding a flower in his hands.

He was toying with one of the yellow daffodils from the vase in his fingers. He twirled it, admiring all the petals. Katsuki turned his eyes to him, and Izuku was frozen in place by how heavy with love they were.

Katsuki smiled at him, with teary eyes. "I think I finally figured out what my mother would say."

Izuku's heart skipped a beat. He looked back with all the love he had in his heart. "What do you think she would say?"

"Well, I think if she met you, she would tell me: 'Oi. *Brat*," Katsuki changed his voice at the end with an amused smirk. "Stop being such a *dick* and go be with that cute guy. I always wanted you to end up with someone sweet like that. Besides, it's a damn miracle someone so nice can tolerate you'." Katsuki chuckled lightly. "Then she would hit me on the head for everything I've done."

Izuku laughed a bit, and Katsuki smiled as well. Slowly, he watched as the handsome man stood up out the chair and kneeled on the futon next to him.

Katsuki gazed at Izuku sweetly and placed the daffodil behind Izuku's ear.

"She would have loved you, darling," Katsuki said with a gentle voice.

Chapter End Notes

Let me know what you think below! <3 This chapter made me cry a bit but it felt cathartic to write. I hope it was the same for all of you ^^ I hope you all have an amazing weekend!!

Chapter 32: Sempre

Chapter Summary

Sempre (Qualifier) - Always

Izuku and Katsuki promise each other ‘always’.

Chapter Notes

Welcome back to this choocoo train of angst!! I'm so happy to have you guys along for this ride!

First, thank you to the LOML, Luna, for betaing like always :D and secondly, I hope you guys enjoy this big helping of fluff ^^ <3 I'm finding I am enjoying just writing cute moments more and more as we go. It helps balance everything out well!

Without further ado, I hope you enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 32 — Sempre

.

.

.

Izuku didn’t take the flower out of his hair that morning.

He happily hummed as he put on his uniform and repeated Katsuki’s words to himself.

“She would have loved you, darling.”

That was more validation than he could ever ask for. He didn’t even know he needed it until that moment. But the thought that Mitsuki would have liked him made him content. He felt thankful that he was lucky enough to be with her son.

As he got primped for the day, the love in his chest for Katsuki bloomed into something novel. It transformed from a burning passion to what he always imagined the feeling of a safe

home to be like: Soft. Familiar. Calming. He felt secure as he looked at his reflection in the bedroom mirror. His eyes fixed on the bright, yellow daffodil.

As he studied the petals, the words from his dream echoed in his ears.

"Take good care of him for me."

He would be sure that happened.

After everything, watching over Katsuki felt right. It was a duty bestowed on him and he accepted every bit of it. But as he pondered this, his thoughts came to a halt.

Izuku looked off to the side when Nana came to mind. The pull in his heart tugged yet again, and he knew the answer to if he could go with her was now, no. He couldn't. The concept of starting a new life without Katsuki, his anchor, felt like no life worth living at all.

As if in sync with his thoughts, Katsuki emerged from the bathroom.

He was fully clothed in the lilac uniform and his wild hair was combed the best it could be. But Izuku noted how his shoulders were stiff as he fiddled with his cell. He twirled the black phone tiredly and put it in his pants pockets.

"Still nothing," Katsuki grumbled.

"It's okay," Izuku said sincerely. He smiled at Katsuki as he walked up to him. "Don't stress out too much about it."

"I know but, *ugh*." Katsuki huffed and rubbed his forehead. "I would feel better if that grumpy bastard at least sent a goddamn text."

"Have you tried to contact anyone else?"

"Yeah. I've called all my old coworkers but they're all on assignments right now. Everyone said the same thing: that the old man should be coming back to the country soon-ish. Apparently, the guy took a no-contact vacation to the Bahamas per doctor's orders. Something about high blood pressure."

Izuku pressed his lips into a thin, pensive line.

He knew that should be bad news, but he wasn't feeling as anxious as he should.

As of today, it had officially been a full week since they arrived at Midnight Sento.

Part of Izuku was worried. But more so, a large part of Izuku was simply grateful for the down time. It was a miracle Tomura hadn't shown up to drag him back to Hadeus. Even more so a miracle that they hadn't been stopped by any Yakuza affiliates.

Izuku had an inkling of hope that they would be afforded as much time as Hiryu was. It had taken them two years to ever find him. However, Izuku corrected himself right after having

that thought. Hiryu hadn't been a priority. Izuku, on the other hand, was. Izuku was *always* Tomura's priority.

But he shook off that thought. Izuku didn't want to jinx it by worrying too much.

"It'll be okay," Izuku decided to say. "Once he comes back to Japan, he'll call, and it'll be fine."

Katsuki shook his head. "I don't know how you can remain so calm right now."

"Well, when I'm with you it's easy to be calm."

Katsuki's worried expression now sparked to life with surprise. He blinked, and then a tiny, lopsided smile bloomed on his face. With a delicate touch, he adjusted the daffodil behind Izuku's ear.

"You always say the sweetest damn things," Katsuki replied softly. "Did you want to keep the flower in your hair all day?"

"I did," Izuku smiled back at him. "Is that silly?"

"Not at all," Katsuki replied.

His eyes glimmered with an idea, and he held a finger up to signal 'hang on'. He walked over to his backpack and shuffled around for something. In his fingers he grasped a tiny object and walked back over to Izuku. He grinned, fully satisfied with his mini mission as he held up a bobby pin.

"Hold still," Katsuki murmured.

He leaned in and carefully pinned down the stem to Izuku's fluffy head of hair. When Katsuki pulled away, he admired Izuku like he was a painting he put the finishing touches on.

"There we go. Won't move an inch for the rest of the day," Katsuki said proudly.

A sudden pounding on the door rattled them both. They jumped a bit and whipped their heads to the loud, abrupt sound.

"Oi! You two are on sauna duty today!" Nemuri shouted from the other side. "Hurry up and get downstairs! You're already five minutes behind schedule!"

"We'll be down in a minute! Sorry about that!" Katsuki shouted back, matching her volume.

The banging subdued and they waited until the sound of her footsteps were out of ear shot. They turned to each other and snickered.

"C'mon," Katsuki said. "Let's hurry and get to work for the day."

They smiled at each other as they walked side by side out the room.

The sauna side of the bathhouse was officially Izuku's least favorite of all the rooms. Mainly because it took forever to clean. By the time they made everything sparkle the way Nemuri liked, Izuku could feel early on-set arthritis knocking at his joints.

The sauna section itself was enormous, filling an entire space large enough for at least a hundred people. Off along the sides were various themed saunas that each piqued interest in their own unique way. One sauna was shaped like an igloo, and it was entitled 'Ice Sauna'. Another next to it was made of pure wood and engraved with delicate designs on the inside. This one was called the 'Bamboo Sauna'.

It went on like this: The Charcoal Sauna, Salt Sauna, Ocher Sauna.

Then lastly the Amethyst Sauna, which was composed of an entire floor of rocks.

It was unique because the inside walls were encrusted with lavender gemstones while the door was glass. It was small enough for a duo and the temperature went up to an alarming 150C.

"It's broken," Nemuri had warned them when they first serviced this room. She had pointed very seriously to the temperature control pad on the side. "Regulation is that saunas absolutely *cannot* go above 75C, otherwise people can literally cook alive in here. But there's a giant warning on the inside to let people know."

Izuku thought about this as he cleaned the glass door for the Amethyst Sauna. He curiously looked at the control pad on the side that had a giant '**DO NOT TOUCH**' sign on it in bright red lettering.

Izuku squatted down and wrung out his purple towel in the bucket.

Katsuki was polishing the tiles next to him. He peered at him occasionally with apprehensive eyes. Behind them was a litany of questions, waiting to be said. Then the first one finally came.

"Have you made up your mind about going with Nana or not?" Katsuki asked in a whisper. "I know you said you were contemplating it. But I think you really need to take it."

Izuku paused and hesitated. He stumbled visibly on his words and looked down to the murky water in the bucket.

Izuku's brows furrowed together. "I'm still not sure."

"What do you mean you're not *sure*?" Katsuki bit back. He put down his scrubber and leaned into Izuku's line of vision with a stern glare. He took Izuku's chin with his fingers and lifted his head. "Izuku. You have *gotta* take it. There's no way you will be safe from that evil ass brother of yours otherwise."

"I know but something is keeping me here," Izuku shamefully whispered.

"*What*? What could be so important that you don't want to get to *safety*?"

"...I don't want to leave you, Kacchan," Izuku admitted.

Katsuki's eyes widened with shock. He blinked rapidly at the admission, then his whole face softened.

"You've been unsure about going because of me?"

"Is that bad?" Izuku asked desperately, truly not knowing. "I don't want to leave you, Kacchan. I can't. I feel as if I physically *can't*. Every time I even think about it, my heart hurts in this *awful* way. How can I go on to a new, happy life knowing you could still be in danger? Or worse, *killed*?"

Katsuki's eyes grew sad, and he dropped his hand. "Izuku…"

Izuku whipped his head away quickly. He knew what Katsuki was going to say.

"I know, it's stupid," Izuku quickly blurted out before Katsuki could. He shook his head and screwed his eyes shut. "I know it's such a *stupid* damn decision. But I can't leave you like this, Katsuki. I care about you too much. I'm staying and you can't make me change my mind."

He waited for Katsuki to shout at him about how priceless this opportunity was.

But it never came. In place of a lecture, he got tender hands rubbing his shoulders. Izuku opened his eyes, and Katsuki fixed him with a subtle, pained smile.

"I was actually going to agree with you," Katsuki admitted. "I don't want to part ways again either."

Those were words Izuku wasn't prepared to hear. He perked up, surprised and unsure.

"Really?" Izuku questioned.

"Of course." Katsuki offered up a smile that felt like a half-lit moon. "I've had some time to process everything, sort of. Not fully, but enough. I've gone over a shit ton of scenarios and analyzed all the probable outcomes. And in every one where we're parting ways, I fuckin' *hate* it. It feels wrong, y'know? Like something really nasty is in my mouth and I get this lump in my throat. So, yeah. We should stay together."

He didn't realize he needed to hear those words from Katsuki. As they sunk in fully, Izuku was overcome with relief. Swiftly, as if every star aligned, it all clicked together like lock and key. His future that used to be so murky was now crystal clear, and the visual in front of him was the two of them.

Izuku asked right away, "Does this mean we should start looking for places to go since Nana is off the table?"

“Oh, no. You’re *definitely* going with Nana,” Katsuki shot down. “There’s no chance in hell I’m letting that not happen.”

Izuku frowned. “But you just said—”

“—I’ve decided I’m coming with you.”

Everything stopped.

Izuku’s eyes widened at that implication: Katsuki was going to start over *with him*.

And starting over meant leaving everything behind, including Katsuki’s burning need for revenge.

The spite that lived inside of Katsuki was like a pile of coals fueling his fire. It was deeply rooted, clearly inherited from his mother. Spite was one of Katsuki’s main reasons to live and because of that, Izuku questioned if it would be so simple for Katsuki to switch gears.

“You were right about the situation with me and the Yakuza,” Katsuki continued. “I’m in as much danger as you are. Now that my head is clearer and shit, I can think more logistically. I need to disappear as well if I ever want a chance to be happy and normal.”

“But what about Chisaki?” Izuku asked, unsure. “You said you had a plan to kill him, you can’t abandon that.”

“Forget I ever mentioned that,” Katsuki replied. There was a bite in his voice, but not towards Izuku. It was for something else. “There is no plan. Your safety is far more important.”

“But you’ve been craving revenge for your mother for *years*,” Izuku emphasized. “If you want, we can go try and kill Chisaki ourselves then try to get back to Nana in time.”

Katsuki didn’t say anything right away.

He took a long, thoughtful pause. It was as if he was picking his words carefully from a shelf and arranging them together.

“Going anywhere near Chisaki is too dangerous, Izuku,” Katsuki said, surprisingly levelheaded. “You shouldn’t be anywhere near him—especially after everything you told me. It’s too dangerous for you.”

“But…your mom,” Izuku whispered.

Solemnness clouded across Katsuki’s face.

“I know,” Katsuki agreed. “As much as it pains me to let that scum keep living, I gotta. The thought of never seeing you again is more painful than letting him live.”

He lifted his gaze and grasped one of Izuku’s hands. He folded the smaller hand inside of his own two large ones and smiled at Izuku with a gentle yet sad resolve.

He said solidly, “if I have to choose between a lifetime of happiness with you or a brief moment of revenge, I choose *you*. It’s what my mom would have wanted for me, I’m sure. But more importantly, it’s what I want for myself.”

The words struck Izuku in the heart.

“Are you positive?” Izuku whispered. “I don’t want you to regret this down the line.”

“I could never regret you, Izuku.”

Tears gathered in Izuku’s eyes. His heart was singing, melting, and soaring all at once. His hands began to lightly shake, and he placed his other hand on top of Katsuki’s folded ones. They looked at each other full of promises, and Izuku felt the shift in the air.

“Let’s promise to never let go again, okay?” Katsuki proposed. “Even if we decide things don’t work out between us down the line, I want us to always be in each other’s lives. No matter what.”

He smiled as his own eyes grew full of tears.

“Okay,” Izuku agreed with his whole heart. He smiled back at Katsuki and two tears of happiness slid down his cheek. “I promise to never let you go, Kacchan.”

“Always?” Katsuki asked.

“Always.” Izuku promised.

The longer Izuku gazed at Katsuki, he saw all the lovely versions of him flash before his eyes. They flickered like a montage in a black and white romantic movie. Every version of Katsuki was coated in stardust and woven with daydreams. They presented themselves in chronological order, from the young Kacchan to the present-day Katsuki.

But now, he saw the future Kacchan. He had age lines and snow-white hair that told the story of their battles and all the turmoil they overcame.

Izuku couldn’t wait to meet him.

“We’re finally going to get a shot of that new life together,” Katsuki said. “I guess it’s time to really start thinking about that flower shop of dead roses we said we were going to open, huh?”

He laughed, full of joy as he wiped Izuku’s tears away. Izuku nervously chuckled with him as he held on tightly to Katsuki. He clung to the lifeline in front of him as he began to imagine their beautiful future that was *truly* now possible.

“Yeah, I guess we do, don't we?” Izuku chuckled back at him. “Maybe we should start thinking about a name for it.”

He began shaking, trying to fully calm down but it was impossible. He was really getting his happy ending. It was so close and in reach for them—for once. They were finally aligned and

all they had to do was make it to Nana. *Together*.

Katsuki gathered him for an embrace and Izuku's heart thumped loudly.

Warm. That was Izuku's first thought. Katsuki's whole body was always so warm in a welcoming way. Izuku memorized this feeling, as this would be his new home. He embraced Katsuki tightly and couldn't contain the joy that bubbled inside of him.

He laughed. He cried. He smiled as he pulled Katsuki closer and closer. Katsuki pulled away briefly, and his eyes were full of stars. The future of hope he held in them shone through as he touched the daffodil in Izuku's hair lovingly.

"Can I kiss you?" Katsuki asked.

Izuku nodded and caressed Katsuki's cheek. "Please do."

They leaned forward, and locked lips in a tender kiss.

It felt like finally coming home.

ᔓᔓᔓ

By the time lunch came, there was a visible pink bubble surrounding Izuku and Katsuki. It was warm and built of sickly-sweet stares. They walked through the hallway towards the dining hall hand in hand. Their joined arms swung lightly in tandem with their stride as they made their way to their normal seats.

When they finally sat down with everyone, neither of them let go and held hands under the table.

"Good afternoon, everyone," Izuku said cheerily. "I hope the morning treated you all well."

Katsuki gave a curt, short nod of acknowledgement to everyone. "Good afternoon."

"Well good afternoon to you too," Nemuri said curiously. "Someone's in a good mood."

"Ah ha, yeah I suppose so," Izuku said aloofly.

His head was too chock full of daydreams to really focus. He smiled happily at Katsuki. In return, Katsuki tried to hide the stupid grin on his face by rubbing his nose and sucking in his lips.

Curious glances were exchanged across the table.

Then Sekijiro came out of the kitchen. He was balancing several plates of food on his arms like he was in the circus. Everyone began hooting as the burly man set down all the food. An alluring steam rolled off the piles of vegetables and Izuku couldn't help but lean over and take a big inhale.

As they began eating, Izuku noted the difference in the atmosphere now. After the lantern festival last night, everyone's moods were beginning to lift like the fog outside. Smiles were flashed around the table as they discussed the influx of guests into the bathhouse this morning.

Izuku popped fruit after fruit in his mouth. The sweet taste of strawberries was always his favorite way to start his lunch. When he ate the last strawberry on his plate, Katsuki immediately noticed.

"Did you want some of my strawberries?" Katsuki asked Izuku. "You finished yours pretty fast."

"Oh! Sure, if you don't mind," Izuku agreed happily. "I love strawberries so much. I always eat them super quickly."

"Yeah. I know, nerd."

Katsuki gently smiled and pierced one piece of strawberry with his fork. He held it up and moved it towards Izuku's mouth without a second thought.

Naturally, Izuku let himself be fed. They had done this a lot while Izuku's ankle was healing. At first Izuku had been shy about it, but now it was as natural as breathing since Katsuki enjoyed doing it so much. Izuku happily hummed as he chewed on the fruit and Katsuki gladly gave him several more slices.

Silence captured the table.

Izuku peeked up to see all four sets of eyes gazing at them.

"Did you guys have a good cleaning session or something?" Nemuri teased, holding back a smile.

It dawned on him what they had done—in front of people. A blush as hot as coals lit up his cheeks. They tried to go back to eating regularly but everyone kept staring at them. Katsuki huffed and put down his fork with a scowl when it went on too long.

"Why are you all looking at us like we have roaches on our faces?" Katsuki blurted out.

Immediately, Izuku elbowed Katsuki in his side. "*Kacchan*—"

"—What? It's true. Look at them, they're all stupidly gawking." Katsuki dramatically waved his hand towards all the snickering people. "Go on. Spit it out, extras."

"Extras!" Sekijiro belted out. He grinned brightly at Katsuki. "What a funny term, I like you."

"Sorry, you have to excuse him," Izuku quickly apologized. He put his hands up in defense and shook his head. "He's not the best with people."

“Honestly, I’m just glad to see some of your personalities coming through,” Nemuri laughed. She leaned back in her chair and smiled brilliantly. “I was beginning to wonder if you two would be like knots on a log after sulking around here for a week.”

“So, you’re just observing us like wild animals?” Katsuki jeered.

“Sort of,” Ryuko said. She shrugged her shoulders. “We’re staring at you because we’ve all been wondering what you two are and uh, this happiness is a new development.”

“I guessed best friends,” Takeyama said with a kind smile. “But now I’m unsure. I don’t think best friends feed each other like that.”

“You don’t have the right kind of friends I think,” Nemuri replied. She winked at Takeyama and wiggled her eyebrows. “I spoon feed my friends all the time.”

Takeyama didn’t seem amused. She scoffed and said, “Which friends? The ones who call you ‘Mistress Midnight’ or the ones you’re *actually* friends with?”

“Both.” Nemuri replied cockily. “Do you want to be one of those friends?”

Jokingly, Nemuri held up her fork that had a piece of egg on it and tried to feed it to Takeyama. The other woman huffed and slapped the utensil out of her face.

“I guessed boyfriends of the sorts with a complicated past,” Sekijiro said, ignoring the scene. “I see the way you two are with each other. It’s very soft.”

“I think you two are exes,” Ryoku added. “Not to be rude but the tension was thick enough to cut with a knife. It was choking us all for the last week on top of everything.”

“So—which is it?” Takeyama pressed.

Both Izuku and Katsuki sat there, flabbergasted. What nosy people.

“Well,” Katsuki said. He scratched his cheek and winced a little. “None of those, technically. We’re legally married so we would be classified as husbands, I suppose.”

Confused, strangled sounds erupted at the table.

“Oh my god! *What*!” Nemuri nearly shouted, drawing the attention of the other people in the dining hall.

Takeyama’s eyes bulged. Nemuri’s mouth dropped. Ryoku hummed as if that made total sense. Then unexpectedly Sekijiro turned to Ryoku and held his hand out in a ‘gimme’ motion and grinned wide.

“Pay up,” Sekijiro demanded with a smirk. “Guessing that they were boyfriends was close enough.”

Ryoku pushed Sekijiro’s hand away. “Absolutely not. *Married* is not the same as *dating*.”

“Wait, you’re really married?” Nemuri asked. She assessed them as if that didn’t make complete sense. “For how long?”

“I-I guess about five months now,” Izuku answered. He turned to Katsuki with nervous flutters in his stomach. Katsuki was gazing at him tenderly and looking him up and down. “But we’ve known each other a long time.”

“Ah, so you’re still newlyweds,” Takeyama said. She was smiling at them kindly now, eager to know more. “This is so cute. You must tell me about your first date. I always love hearing about them when people are married.”

Izuku froze. Katsuki stiffened.

It dawned on them that they had very much done no such thing. The two of them were always simply around each other, colliding like opposed natural disasters.

“Our timeline has been complicated given, y’know, life circumstances,” Katsuki grumbled.

There was enough edge in his voice that communicated ‘back off’ and everyone took the hint. Takeyama and Sekijiro made the subject change to gush about what a cute couple they make while Ryoku smiled quietly at them.

Izuku began to wonder, did the carnival in Okinawa count as a date? It had felt like one until the Ferris wheel. But then he thought about their time at the estate. Every day seemed like a date, and truly Izuku felt like they had been in a relationship after a while.

They had confessed their feelings—but he guessed they never actually made it official.

Izuku looked at Katsuki beside him who was talking to Takeyama.

He began blushing thinking about asking Katsuki to be his partner. It felt silly at this point, but the romantic side of him craved it. He lightly put his hand over Katsuki’s on the table and decided not to worry about it. They moved at their own, unique pace.

When Katsuki entwined their hands, they both missed the weary gaze from Nemuri.



After lunch they began the second part of their days. Katsuki, Ryoku and Sekijiro were put on inventory duty since they could do most of the heavy lifting. Takeyama and other employees Izuku didn’t know very well serviced private rooms.

During this time, Izuku always went off with Nemuri. They would be in the backroom organizing out the different soaps, towels, and snack trays that would be given to guests later in the day.

Truthfully, this was the part of the day Izuku had grown to appreciate the most. Or as much as he could. He was still getting used to this new sense of freedom he had. But it was hard, like trying to adjust to a state of gravity-less limbo.

It was odd to use his hands for some other type of work that didn't involve bloodshed.

But he found that filling his time with tedious tasks helped. This way when he counted the nth purple towel, he didn't have too much room to unwillingly mourn the life he left behind.

That was the scary part. Occasionally this past week, he found himself unintentionally missing Tokyo. He figured that was the point of their upbringing though, right? He missed the comfortability of the king-sized bed and all the food he could imagine. The luxury bathtubs and showers with a room big enough for four people had made a padded life.

But really, he mostly missed Katsuma's smile.

The brotherly love they cultivated kept him grounded.

More so, he missed Ibara too and how they would dress up together. He thought fondly on the days she would gush over putting different products in his hair and dolling him up. He also missed Aoyama. He missed the way Aoyama would play card games with him late at night. He even missed Jin to an extent, if only for the routine familiarity of his crude humor.

But worst of all, a tiny part of Izuku missed Tomura.

He didn't want to.

He wanted to loathe Tomura with every fiber of his being. He wanted to spite him and only see the horrible, sick side of his brother. But there was a single fiber in him that did miss Tomura. It was the small child version of him that would cry in the middle of the night and then be hushed back to sleep by his brother. It made him angry with himself.

But he tried to take it in stride. Because even though he now hated Tomura, Tomura always was going to be the person who raised him. Whether he liked it or not.

As he pondered this, Izuku delicately folded the purple towel into the shape of a swan.

He pointed the wing, and proudly surveyed it. Then he carefully placed it on the shelf alongside the other hundreds of swan-towelettes he had created.

Nemuri was beside him, but she was unusually quiet. Normally she would be talking his ear off and gushing about what a good listener he was. But instead, she seemed apprehensive.

"Izuku, can I ask you a very serious question?" Nemuri suddenly said.

"Of course," Izuku replied.

"Nana mentioned you were raised in the Viper Academy, is that actually true?" Nemuri asked, cutting straight to the point.

She turned to him with a straight face. She was dead serious and seemed terribly concerned for him.

“It is,” Izuku said seriously. He straightened his back and tightened his lips. “That wasn’t a lie, I swear.”

“You don’t seem like it,” Nemuri noted cautiously. “I used to know someone from there when I was still in my assassin days. They were not kind. They were *deliberately* cruel. It was as if they went out of their way to be horrible and you’re not like that at all.”

“I had some external influences growing up,” Izuku admitted. “Specifically, Katsuki. I retained a large part of my empathy because of him.”

Nemuri nodded, but still was visibly confused.

“Who did you know exactly?” Izuku asked. “Usually, we’re not supposed to mingle with outsiders. It’s surprising you know someone.”

“I don’t know her personally, she tried to kill me on several accounts. I never found out her name, but she had the number 21 under her eye. Do you happen to know who that is?”

He did.

“Yes, she’s one of the heads of the academy,” Izuku answered past the lump in his throat. “Ms. Nagant is what she goes by if that’s something you want to know. She’s one of the top assassins in her own cohort and manages the logistics in the academy because of how thorough she is.”

“Thorough is one goddamn word for it,” Nemuri muttered. She crossed her arms and frowned. “She *ruined* my life. I had run into her on a mission and overheard about that Academy while hiding. I was found out and she basically hunted me down to the end of earth until I needed to go into hiding. I gave up being an assassin because of her. Nana had to help me cover my tracks and set me up here for the last twelve years.”

“Does that mean you were the one who told Nana about The Academy?”

“I sure was,” Nemuri said sternly. “I must admit, it really is confusing that you’re as sweet as you are. I don’t have the best impression about snakes.”

“Thank you, I think.” Izuku smiled the best he could.

“But with that being said, I think you should come with me.”

Nemuri’s eyes hardened into a familiar lethality. Izuku recognized it, he had seen it several times in Katsuki and even in Tomura. It was beginning to dawn on Izuku that Nemuri was no average person.

She jutted her head towards the door and then led him out into the hallway. As they walked, on the way they passed Katsuki and Sekijiro who were carrying five large boxes each. Izuku gave a tiny wave and Katsuki winked at him as they crossed paths.

Nemuri caught this and looked between them with increased weariness.

They came to a stairwell Izuku had always passed but never used. It led down into the basement.

“I should have done this earlier, but I was distracted by the mayor’s daughter’s passing,” Nemuri said as they walked down the long staircase. “But today, seeing how close you and Katsuki are, I finally understand the full gravity of this situation.”

“What do you mean by our closeness?” Izuku asked, unsure.

“I mean Katsuki is a weakness for you and vice versa,” Nemuri said. “There’s strength in numbers but there’s also clear Achilles heels. When you expose your heart strings to your enemy, you give them an opportunity for them to control you through them.”

Izuku sucked in a breath at that.

He knew now why she was so concerned—and he was suddenly disturbed too. She was hinting at the very real possibility that Katsuki could be hurt, or captured, in order to control him.

“I understand what you’re saying,” Izuku agreed. “We’ll do our best to keep sharp.”

“Good. I’ll also try my best to help make sure that’s possible.”

When they finally came to the belly of the basement, all that awaited them was a dark purple door.

It shined like it was made of gems. Nemuri opened it with a black key and pushed the door open.

She flicked on the lights and Izuku was taken back by what was on the walls.

Floggers. Underwear. Condoms, dildos, and a *plethora* of vibrators in different colors were sitting on shelves. Directly next to what was possibly the most impressive collection of flavored lubes were different whips. And next to those, hanging up like a first-place trophy were ball gags.

Izuku made a strangled, confused sound and froze on the spot.

Nemuri turned towards him, entirely confused as to why he was confused.

Izuku clasped his hands together and took a step back. “I-I don’t think me, or Katsuki need anything from here. There might be some sort of misunderstanding. We’re married but—”

“—Oh! We’re not getting anything from *here*, silly,” Nemuri replied. She laughed and waved her hand at him. “We’re going to my other room. Sorry about that. We have to get through my secondary business rooms first to go where we’re heading.”

Izuku nodded stiffly as he stared at a pink leash that said ‘princess’ on it.

He blushed so hard he was sure he was going to be red the rest of the day.

Nemuri chuckled and waved him in. “C’mon, this stuff isn’t going to *bite* you.”

Izuku followed behind the tall woman with his head lowered. He tried his best not to stare too long at the different items. But it was hard. He had a terribly strong sense of curiosity, and he couldn’t help but peek.

There were several things in here that made Izuku’s ears burn from the implication of how they could be used. He recognized some of these things from the box Katsuki had kept under their bed at the estate. But many of these toys he had no clue what they could be for.

Once they made it out of the quasi sex store, they passed through another dark hallway. They walked by one red room that was perched off to the side. Izuku curiously peeked in the open door and was further scandalized to see a sex dungeon.

Izuku quickly averted his eyes and covered his mouth.

They finally came to a halt at the very end of the hallway. Nemuri had led him to another room that was all the way in the back, unlabeled. She unlocked it with the same black key and Izuku realized why she had brought him down here.

All along the wall were weapons.

Each wall held a different assortment of weapons. On one wall were countless guns. On the other was the most beautiful arrangement of blades Izuku had ever seen. And on another were maces and other weapons that would be classified as expensive such as the guando.

“These are all from my old assassin days,” Nemuri explained, slipping back to seriousness. She stepped forward and grabbed the long guando off the wall. She sentimentally dragged her finger up its pole. “I don’t have much use for them anymore since I was forced into retirement. But I keep it here in case my past ever decides to come knocking on my door.”

“Your blade collection is beautiful,” Izuku complimented. “A lot of these are super rare.”

“And they’re made of even rarer metal,” Nemuri replied. “Ryoku and Takeyama come from a very long line of blacksmiths. They know how to make a blade that cuts cleanly through flesh and bone with ease. What’s your preferred weapon type?”

“I usually always had twin blades or was equipped with small knives. But I didn’t have time to grab anything other than guns before fleeing.”

“Well then, help yourself,” Nemuri urged.

She stepped to the side and let Izuku have at it. He suddenly felt timid, almost hesitant. But he looked at the tall wall that held over a hundred blades and felt a semblance of home. Two blades in the middle caught the light and Izuku’s attention.

He stepped forward, drawn to it like a siren song.

They were long, black daggers that were coated in obsidian and curved ever so slightly.

They reminded him of Hiryu in a way, and this alone made Izuku pick up one of them.

“Ah, I see you have great taste,” Nemuri said with humor. She stepped forward as well and smiled at Izuku. “I used to love these. They were my favorite choice of weapon when I was your age. They got the job done amazingly.”

Izuku turned his head towards her. “I can choose something else if they’re sentimental to you.”

“Nonsense,” Nemuri shot back and shook her head. “They’ll get good use from you, I’m sure. But I do have one condition that I ask of you if you’re going to take my favorite blades.”

“What is it?”

Nemuri picked up the other blade and handed it to him.

“Make sure to kill a lot of snakes,” she commanded scornfully.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku thoughtfully looked at the twin blades while in the guest bedroom. He stared at himself in the blackness of the blade and could only find his shining green eyes.

After hearing Nemuri’s story, he wondered how many other people’s lives had been poisoned by the venom of his family. Their reach was further than Izuku ever really knew. And that made him all the wearier. Because if the Vipers were this terrifying, that only increased the chances of Chisaki wanting a merge as much as Tomura.

With careful hands, Izuku wrapped up the twin blades in a sweater.

He also packed in dozens of tiny knives Nemuri found for him. He felt shielded again, happily equipped with what he knew he could be nearly unstoppable with.

Right after he packed up all the blades, he assessed the bag and a sense of paranoia finally kicked in. He then quickly unzipped it and grabbed the twin blades. He secured them, entirely unseen, in the back of his uniform’s sash for easy access and let out a shaky breath.

He checked the blue clock in the room. His small break was over.

ᔓᔓᔓ

He went back downstairs with a head full of viper related thoughts and Katsuki.

On his way back to the inventory room, he spotted Katsuki peeking around with something hidden behind his back.

Katsuki turned his head around like he was looking for someone, and when his eyes finally landed on Izuku, his whole face lit up with a smile. Izuku waved happily as Katsuki began

walking towards him and soon, they met in the middle of the hallway.

“How’s the second half of your shift going?” Izuku asked.

“Good, good,” Katsuki said. He shifted on his feet awkwardly. “Me and Sekijiro had a good talk about life and stuff.”

“About *life*?” Izuku laughed. “I think this is a first. I’ve never seen you open up to someone you recently met. What did you guys talk about that thawed your shell?”

Katsuki didn’t answer. Instead, a slightly pink blush graced his cheeks as he searched Izuku’s eyes.

Izuku tilted his head, confused at the silence.

Suddenly, Katsuki cleared his throat and brought what he was hiding forward. Like a giant ray of sunshine, a massive bouquet of bright yellow flowers filled Izuku’s whole vision. A gorgeous combination of daffodils, marigolds, and roses sprung to life in front of him.

“For you,” Katsuki said quickly with his lopsided grin. “They match the one in your hair.”

He gently handed the flowers to Izuku and smiled fully.

Izuku took the flowers, totally caught off guard. “O-Oh, thank you, Kacchan. These are beautiful.”

“Exactly like you,” Katsuki added smoothly. “A perfect match.”

Izuku blushed deeply and hid his face behind the flowers a bit. The heat sank down from his face to his neck and Izuku laughed nervously.

“I almost forgot for a moment how shy you are with compliments.” Katsuki chuckled. He peeked around the flowers to get a better look at Izuku while wearing an attractive smirk. “You really are a little nerd sometimes. Why does being called beautiful make you blush? I know for certain everyone calls you beautiful in Tokyo.”

“It only makes me blush when you say it,” Izuku admitted. “I don’t know why, but it’s only you.”

Katsuki’s eyes softened and he stepped forward with confidence. They met eyes for a tender second.

“Do you want to go out on a date with me?” Katsuki asked.

Izuku felt himself short-circuit. He blinked rapidly and stared wildly at Katsuki. “A date?”

“Yeah, an official one.” Katsuki leaned in, making Izuku blush more. “I realize we did this all sorts of fucked up and you like all that lovey dovey stuff.”

“But we went on plenty of dates while we were in Biei,” Izuku said. “A lot actually. I think we even went back to that Thai place fifteen times.”

“But those weren’t really *dates*,” Katsuki emphasized. “We were only going out for dinner. There were no flowers or whatever type of sappy shit they do in the movies. I think one film you made me watch had a boom box or something? I don’t want you to miss out on that stuff, you love it too much.”

“That’s very sweet, but we don’t have to do all that for my sake, Kacchan,” Izuku said. He thought it was nice that Katsuki was thinking of Izuku’s romanticism. “I’m happy being with you wherever.”

“Okay, but what if I kinda *like* the idea of trying to woo you?” Katsuki admitted shyly. Now it was his turn to blush as he rubbed his neck. “I’ve been thinking about it since lunch, and it would be kind of nice to make you blush and swoon over candlelight dinner. It sounds sort of…intimate or whatever.”

It was here Izuku realized Katsuki really *was* a romantic. Izuku nearly stopped breathing at the revelation. Underneath all that tough exterior, Katsuki was as hopelessly eager for romance as Izuku was.

“Okay,” Izuku said softly. “I’ll go on a date with you, Kacchan.”

“Really?”

“Yeah, of course.”

Katsuki grinned as bright as the sun. Izuku had never seen such love and light spark in his eyes as he did in this moment. Katsuki seemed like he could barely contain himself as he straightened out his posture and took a flirtatious pose.

“Okay, get ready for the best date of your life, nerd,” Katsuki playfully teased. Izuku laughed and Katsuki tilted his head at him. “Hey—I mean it. I don’t like to half ass anything, and that includes this.”

“I believe it,” Izuku grinned back, mood lightening all the way. “When is this date then?”

“Tonight. I’ll come pick you up from our guest bedroom right before dinner.”

Izuku made an amused face. “Pick me up? From inside the bathhouse?”

“Mhm. I’m a real gentleman, don’t you know?” Katsuki winked at Izuku. “Be sure to wear whatever you think is the fanciest stuff you own. I might go bathhouse chic tonight; it seems to be all the rage right now.”

Izuku laughed from the bottom of his belly when Katsuki brushed off the collar of his uniform.

“I think I might go bathhouse chic as well,” Izuku teased. “I hope you don’t mind us matching.”

“I don’t think I would mind at all. Matching outfits already on the first date? I think we got most of these extras beat in the romance game.”

Izuku chuckled genuinely and Katsuki did too. The melodic laughter mixed and a light around them glowed the same as the flowers in Izuku’s hands. When the chuckles tapered off, they looked at each other as soft as a sunset.

Suddenly, Sekijiro’s booming voice yelled Katsuki’s name from down the hall. He called to him to help him move some shelves downstairs and Katsuki yelled back in an equally loud voice. Katsuki turned to Izuku with a light in his eye.

“Okay, that’s my cue to get back to work,” Katsuki said, reluctantly. He began backing away and did a two-finger salute. “I’ll see you later tonight. Don’t be late for our date!”

“Wouldn’t dream of it,” Izuku yelled, shouting after Katsuki as he took off down the hall.

When he was out of sight, all Izuku could feel was warmth.

He gazed down at the lovely flowers and truly understood the depth of Nemuri’s warning. They had finally found a clear path to peace, but the price of it might cost them everything if they were not careful.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Later that day, Izuku did exactly as they planned.

He waited in their room and spruced himself up. He readjusted the flower behind his ear and made sure to brush his curls in a way that complimented him.

There was an underlying giddiness to all of this Izuku had to admit. He finally was going on the date with the person he always wanted. The circumstances might not have been the *best*, but any scenario with Kacchan always felt right.

When Katsuki knocked on the door, Izuku felt his heart jump.

He smoothed out his uniform and answered the door with a smile. Awaiting him was Katsuki, also in his uniform. His hands were clasped behind his back and there was a tinge of pink along his cheeks. He glanced Izuku up and down and then nervously rubbed his neck.

“Damn,” Katsuki said with a tiny chuckle. “I probably should have saved the flowers for now, huh? I messed that up somehow, didn’t I?”

“You can make up for it by giving me your hand,” Izuku replied with a flirtatious smile. “You don’t always need to give flowers on the first date.”

Katsuki dryly chuckled. “Got it Mr. Romance Expert.”

Katsuki extended his hand and they both clasped on tight. As they walked down the hall together, Izuku couldn’t help but grin like a fool. His cheeks were beginning to hurt as he

leaned into Katsuki.

“Y’know, this is my first real date,” Izuku admitted shyly.

“Well that makes me a lucky guy, doesn’t it? I’ll make sure to give you the best date you’ve ever known.”

ᔓᔓᔓ

They stopped at the Galaxy room. Katsuki opened the door and sitting inside was a romantic setup that soared far beyond even Izuku’s expectations.

The whole room was dimmed, lights low enough that it allowed the projected stars to really have their moment. In the middle of the room on top of a plush black comforter was a kotatsu bearing a purple blanket. Three candles sat in the center and already on the tabletop a delicious meal of various fish, vegetables, and steak was laid out.

Izuku was taken back.

“This is amazing,” Izuku whispered. “How did you put this together in such a short time?”

Katsuki smirked, beyond pleased with himself. “Sekijiro was kind enough to make us his best dishes tonight. I told him I wanted to give you a nice dinner date but was disappointed since we can’t exactly step foot outside for a while.”

Katsuki led him by their joined hands towards the table and they sat down across from each other. As Izuku made himself cozy on the plush pillow, their legs tangled underneath the blanket covering. He also noted the bottle of white wine on the table and the white roses gently littered around.

Izuku gazed up at the twinkling stars and felt a sense of wonder flood into him. It felt like they weren’t in a bathhouse anymore, but a beautiful point of time that was their own.

“Thank you, Kacchan,” Izuku said sincerely. “Really, thank you. This is so nice.”

“You deserve nice things,” Katsuki replied simply. He popped open the bottle of wine and poured them both a quarter glass. “Let’s eat up, darling.”

Izuku felt himself swooning, and it was obvious that didn’t go unnoticed to his ‘date’. A pleased spark ignited in Katsuki’s eyes, and he grinned at Izuku coyly. He playfully rocked their joined legs as he pushed the glass of wine towards Izuku.

He had to give it to Katsuki because he was right. This was a fun thing to do.

They blended into a natural conversation and laughed about their day at work together.

Katsuki admitted that Sekijiro got him to open up by talking about their marriage. He said once he started talking about it, everything else came out easily. Katsuki mentioned how he now understood Izuku was a soft spot for him.

Izuku smiled at that. He sipped on the white wine and felt more special than he ever had in his life.

Later in the conversation, Izuku couldn't hold back from explaining the sex dungeon in the basement that he saw. Apparently, this was hilarious because Katsuki practically howled in laughter.

"You couldn't tell that she was a dominatrix?" Katsuki laughed.

"N-No!" Izuku shot back. He shook his head furiously and harshly whispered, "how was I supposed to know *that*?!"

"Oh. There were *definitely* hints. She even talked about her 'other services' when we first arrived and how she hand feeds her friends. C'mon. It was like, right *there*. Damn, I forget you're a little bit innocent until moments like this."

"I am not innocent," Izuku snapped back with no bite. A rosy blush filled his cheeks. "O-Or at least I'm not anymore. I'm only a little undereducated about *stuff* like this."

"*Stuff*? Kinky sex you mean?"

"Shh, keep your voice down, Kacchan!"

Katsuki continued to nearly bend over in laughter.

They finished up their meal and Izuku felt warm and full in the best ways possible. The stars in the background against Katsuki's warm color palette was truly lovely to him. As he stared across the candlelight, Katsuki cocked his head.

"I think this is the part where you continue to teach me how to be in love," Katsuki mentioned after they finished their meal. "Isn't that the deal we made?"

Izuku let out a short, amused scoff. "You don't need any more pointers, Kacchan. You've watched all the same movies I have now and you're doing a great job at this so far."

Katsuki shrugged. "Doesn't hurt to make sure I'm doing it right. So, what type of questions do people ask on first dates typically?"

Izuku decided to humor him. He hummed thoughtfully and placed his finger on his chin.

"Well. Usually, they try to get to know each other and see if their futures align well," Izuku explained. "A lot of questions typically happen here, and they enjoy each other's company to see if they're a good match."

"Basically, we're feeling out the vibe?"

"Sure, ya. We're feeling out 'the vibe', hah."

"Well. How about this, I'll look up some of those corny first date questions and we'll go down the list to make this authentic."

Izuku smiled, shook his head but didn't stop Katsuki. His date pulled out his black phone and began typing and scrolling. Izuku watched as Katsuki's face contorted with a couple varying emotions. He frowned then scrunched his nose and frowned even deeper as he began to aggressively scroll.

Izuku tilted his head. "Are none of the questions good?"

"Not that. I think we both know a lot of these already."

He turned his phone around to show Izuku some of the questions. With his pointer finger, Izuku leisurely scrolled down the list.

Favorite color? *Red*. Favorite food? *Anything Spicy*. Passions? *Classical music composition.* What does a perfect weekend look like to you? Izuku already knew Katsuki would want to have a slow morning, listen to a classical music record while eating and then go hiking.

"Wow, you're right," Izuku laughed. "Seems like we've already done a good job at getting to know each other."

"We're killing it with this whole romance thing," Katsuki charmingly said. He turned his phone back around and then kept scrolling. Then he stopped with a curious hum. "Ah. Here's one that I think is pretty good. What would you say is your worst habit?"

Izuku thought for a moment then said, "I think my stuttering is my worst habit. I don't think I'll ever get rid of it fully."

"Really? You think that's your worst habit?" Katsuki frowned deeply. "I think the way you stutter is cute. It's very, *Izuku*. Plus, it lets me know when I officially made you flustered."

Izuku's face burned. "Th-That's not true."

Shit.

Katsuki grinned. "Sure it's not."

To hide his embarrassment, Izuku shyly tucked a hair behind his ear and cleared his throat. He looked at Katsuki expectantly and said, "well, now it's your turn. What would you say your worst habit is?"

"I think I would say my cursing," Katsuki answered easily. "I can't stop it if I tried—and I really did try. My coworkers set up a swear jar for me once, a nickel for every swear word. I wound up losing twenty dollars within the day. They said forget it because they didn't want me to be broke by the end of the year."

"Interesting," Izuku said without thinking. "I was going to say the way you chew."

Katsuki's eyes bulged. "Hah? My *chewing*?"

"Only sometimes!" Izuku quickly amended. He nervously chuckled and tried to hide behind a sweet smile. "You smack loudly when you're not really thinking. I remember a moment at

the estate you basically attacked the steak you cooked like a caveman. It was *horrible*. I had to put in my headphones to stop from throwing my slipper at you right there."

Shock took over Katsuki's face. His mouth dropped open and he looked falsely scandalized. "Oh my god. Okay, noted. I eat like a fucking *caveman*. Thanks for that."

"I'm sorry!" Izuku apologized but couldn't help but laugh. "I didn't mean anything bad by it! The chewing is a little bit endearing."

"Oh no. Don't try to smooth it out *now*," Katsuki quipped back also with a laugh. They both chuckled and Izuku tried to slap a hand over his mouth as Katsuki began to eat the next bite of his meal quietly. "Next question. What's your favorite childhood memory?"

This was an easy one.

"Every moment in the nook with you," Izuku said. "I loved reading to you. Every time there was a word you didn't know, I felt so happy I could tell you what it was. I know you called me a nerd because of it, but it was really the highlight of my days and got me through adulthood."

Pain flashed in Katsuki's eyes.

"What was yours?" Izuku tried to say, shifting the topic off his depressing childhood.

"Mine is the days we would dance under the light of the stained glass," Katsuki whispered.

Izuku's eyes were now filled with pain as well. He realized that even though they had only spent a year together in an abandoned building, they were the highlight of each other's childhood. In a way, that was sad. Comforting, but sad.

A distant smile graced Katsuki's lips as he took a small sip of his wine.

He said, "there was one day it was so bright outside, so the colors were super vibrant. You were humming *The Dance of the Love Birds* and giggling as you twirled around under the spots of red, blue, and green. I had stopped and watched you spin around and around."

Katsuki smiled, lost in the memory. He dragged his finger thoughtfully around the rim of his wine glass.

"I think that was the moment I knew I wanted to always be around you," Katsuki finished softly.

Izuku reached across the table to hold Katsuki's hand. His date clasped back, and they looked at each other with a silent understanding.

After that, they continued down the list. Eventually they found a couple other questions that they thought were good. They learned more about each other and now, Izuku felt like he was beginning to really know Katsuki in and out.

"Alright. Last question: What kind of house would you want?" Katsuki asked.

“Is that on the list?” Izuku questioned. “That seems like kind of a heavy first date question.”

“Naw, it’s not on the list,” Katsuki admitted. “I’m asking because I’m thinking ahead. If we had the chance to choose, what kind of home would you want to live in?”

“I never gave it too much thought,” Izuku said. He leaned forward and looked at the flickering flame that danced between them. “Something modest, maybe.”

“Modest?” Katsuki asked. “You want something small?”

“Yeah. I’ve lived in a large penthouse for so long that I don’t equate luxe with happiness anymore,” Izuku explained. He tried not to frown, but the sourness slipped in. “Something fancy would make me feel…*trapped*. I think a small home would be good, and potentially near a lot of greenery. Maybe a forest in the back?”

“That sounds great,” Katsuki agreed. “I think the countryside would be nice for us.”

For us.

Izuku liked the sound of that, and he could picture their future home fluidly.

Katsuki cleared his throat and then jutted his head behind him. “I think it might be time for the second round of the date I have planned.”

“What would that be?” Izuku asked curiously.

“Dessert and a bubble bath.” Katsuki grinned wide. “I figured that would be great to wrap up the night since we have unlimited access to this stuff.”

Izuku couldn’t help but blush. “Hah. That does sound amazing, you think of the best ideas.”

Katsuki cockily smiled, stood up, and gestured for Izuku to follow him to the other side of the large room.

On this side of the room, Izuku was surprised to see one of the tubs already filled with steaming hot water and lilac bubbles. All around it were lavender candles that were lit and a tray of Izuku’s favorite desserts was perched near the edge. The water reflected the projected galaxies and beckoned to them to get lost inside of its void.

Katsuki carefully walked around to the radio that was inside of the wall and began to tinker with it. He turned it on, and the sound blared through the speakers overhead. He searched through the stations until he stopped on one that was playing classical music.

Izuku smiled as he watched his date’s face turn satisfactory. Katsuki spun on his heel and smirked at him.

“Some mood music,” Katsuki said flirtatiously, dropping his voice.

Izuku bashfully giggled. “The perfect kind.”

Katsuki walked over to the bath and put his fingers in to test the water. He hummed happily and said, “Great. It’s still hot. Did you want to get in?”

Izuku nodded. “I do, as long as you join me.”

“Oh, I wouldn’t *dream* of leaving your cute ass in there alone.”

They both began to strip down a little too eagerly, and neatly placed their clothes off to the side. Katsuki got in first and Izuku studied the way his date’s muscles danced under his skin. He couldn’t stop the way his eyes crawled down Katsuki’s back.

Scars were littered all over, and he noticed so many new ones. The ones that stood out the most were the fingernail marks from a week ago. They were from when Izuku broke free of the zip ties and clawed his hands down Katsuki’s back during their passionate night.

Katsuki dipped into the water fully and leaned against the edge. He let out a shaky breath and then beckoned for Izuku to get in with him.

More than happy to follow him, Izuku slowly got in feet first.

The searing heat against his skin startled him at first then he slowly adjusted to it. He smiled the whole time as Katsuki snickered. When Izuku finally was able to get fully seated in the water, he felt like he could turn to putty right there. He exhaled, and all the tenseness in his body wafted away with the steam.

“Holy shit,” Izuku exhaled. “This feels amazing, Kacchan.”

“Damn good, right?” Katsuki chuckled and waded towards him in the water. “I knew this is something you would like. You’ve been wound up tighter than a goddamn jack in the box and same for me. We both needed this for sure.”

Izuku playfully pushed the bubbles around and smiled at the sweet aroma.

He looked at Katsuki and made quick work to put some on top of his head. He giggled as he made a fake bubble beard on his date and Katsuki tried to stifle a laugh. He stole a quick kiss from Izuku, putting bubbles on his face too. They began to sink into the water and push around the glittery soap without a care in the world.

After doing this, Izuku eyed the gunshot wound on Katsuki’s arm that was wrapped up. A hint of guilt bit into him and Izuku couldn’t help but pick up his hand and lightly touch the bandage.

“I’m sorry about this, by the way,” Izuku said.

“You have nothing to be sorry for,” Katsuki corrected. “You were only shooting out of self-defense.” Katsuki reached down in the water and lightly touched where Izuku’s gunshot wounds were as well. “*I’m* the one who should be sorry. And I am. I’m really, *really* fucking sorry.”

Izuku was about to speak, but a lump of sadness hit his throat. “I-It’s okay.”

Suddenly, he was then gently guided to sit down on the underwater seat. Katsuki positioned himself behind him, and Izuku nuzzled directly between Katsuki's legs, allowing himself to be swallowed up in the water. He leaned back as Katsuki's arm wrapped around him.

The song on the radio switched to something softer.

He gazed up at the countless twinkling stars above them as Katsuki began kneading different parts of his muscles. The strong, calloused fingers lingered the most on his legs, pressing into the deep tissue of his thighs that was tight from the injuries.

Izuku closed his eyes, shuddered, and tilted his head back against Katsuki's shoulder.

A light kiss was planted on his temple. "Feelin' good?"

"Ye-Yeah," Izuku answered, a little breathless.

Katsuki pressed his fingers in more. "Let me know if there's anything else you need."

They enjoyed the silent moment, and Izuku took the opportunity to knead his fingers into Katsuki's body too. They laid there, soaking up the warmth. When the stillness felt like home, Katsuki spoke again.

"Well, I guess that leaves one more question for the night," Katsuki said in a low voice. "Will you officially be mine, Izuku? If you say no, I get it. I won't be mad."

Izuku's heart filled with what he could only describe as a golden radiance. He smirked up at Katsuki and poked his cheek.

"Ah, I don't know. It *is* only the first date," Izuku teased, lightening the mood. "You already have me naked in a bubble bath massaging my legs. Don't you think we're moving a bit too fast?"

Katsuki shrugged. "We'll move at whatever pace you like."

"Then of course, I would love to be yours," Izuku said joyfully. "Will you be mine as well?"

"I've always been yours."

Izuku's eyes filled with unconditional love, and it was returned to him tenfold. He sat up from his position and turned around to face Katsuki. Protective arms wrapped around his body and held him closely. Love filled the room as Izuku leaned his weight lightly on top of his date with a grin.

"So should I call you my husband or my boyfriend now?" Izuku asked.

Katsuki scoffed. "Husband for sure. There's no way in hell I'm getting downgraded to *boyfriend*."

"Okay, good. I'm happy to hear that because I think husband suits you."

“Damn right it does. It suits you too, Bakugou Izuku,” Katsuki said happily.

Izuku’s heart soared high. The excitement he felt was profound and he couldn’t stop himself from leaning in and nuzzling their noses together. To his surprise and delight, Katsuki nuzzled back and stole a quick kiss. They looked at each other with refreshed, new eyes and all Izuku wanted to do was bask in this type of joy.

If this is what they had to look forward to in their new life, Izuku was more than willing to do whatever it took to make sure they got it.

Then one last curious thing crossed his mind.

“I do have a small question for you, since we’re on the topic of our marriage,” Izuku asked.

“Of course,” Katsuki replied, and drew hearts along Izuku’s skin. “Ask away, darling.”

Izuku bit his lip and said, “Did you ever get the divorce papers I mailed to you? I had asked my sister to send them, but I'm having some doubts they ever made it to you. However, she wasn’t the type to go through people’s mail, and she always did me favors when I asked her.”

Katsuki frowned and sat up a bit. “Uhh, I never got any divorce papers.”

“Really?” Izuku tilted his head. “I sent them to the estate.”

“I haven’t been there in a full month,” Katsuki admitted. “I left out the second I was able to move again. I went to Yokohama, got my tracking gear from my apartment there, and headed straight for Tokyo to find you. If she mailed them, they’re probably sitting in my mailbox.”

Izuku thought about it for a moment.

He hummed and reviewed the night of the masquerade in such a different light. Wow. They had been so heavily misaligned and didn’t even realize it.

Now, Katsuki made a sour face. He asked in a mildly indignant tone, “Wait. You *actually* tried to divorce me? And you did it through the goddamn *mail*?”

“I thought it was the best thing to do at the time?” Izuku cringed and offered up an apologetic smile.

Katsuki’s mouth dropped open, officially offended. “You *nerd*. I can’t believe you—”

He shook his head and began to relentlessly tickle Izuku. A surprised gasp shot out from Izuku’s mouth, and he flailed in the water, causing it to splash everywhere. He tried to get away through his laughing fit, but Katsuki held him in place as his fingers feathered up and down his sides without mercy.

“K-Kacchan!” Izuku squealed out through his laughter. He tried to wiggle as the bubbles flew everywhere. “I-I’m sorry! Have mercy!”

“Nu-uh! Not until you promise not to try to divorce me like that *ever* again,” Katsuki chastised with a wicked smirk. “I told your ass I didn’t want a divorce, you thought I was joking about that?”

“I-I’m sorry!” Izuku laughed uncontrollably. More water splashed around, and bubbles kicked up into the air. “I’m sorry, I promise not to divorce you like that ever again!”

Katsuki smiled and brought their noses together as Izuku cooled down from his laughter. He cupped Izuku’s face and planted a tiny kiss on his nose.

“Good. Sorry to say, but I think you’re stuck with me,” Katsuki said.

Izuku smiled and returned the kiss. “I wouldn’t have it any other way.”

ᔓᔓᔓ

That night, they went to sleep, and it felt like they washed off all the anguish that was trapped inside of their bodies. They laid side by side giggling and whispering all night, riding the high of their ‘first date’. When they went to sleep, they fell into their slumber holding hands.

The next morning when they woke up, they were still in the same mood.

Izuku couldn’t wait for more memories like these.

ᔓᔓᔓ

The next day, they decided to keep on ‘dating’.

This time, they had their first official date as husbands, and made an excuse to have another private dinner. Nemuri didn’t mind. In fact, she seemed happy to see them giddy like two lovebirds fluttering around the bathhouse.

For this date, Katsuki took him to the Sakura Blossom room.

The pink hues all around made Izuku feel like they really were in some type of romantic novel. They ate Izuku’s favorite meal and laughed at different memories and jokes. They found themselves discussing random topics like major events and even their favorite types of comedians. They discussed fashion, places they would like to travel and more.

Truly, they found themselves aligned in more ways than one. It was like aligning two halves of a whole.

During this date, Izuku felt like he was growing closer to Katsuki in a way they hadn’t before.

While their time in Biei had been beautiful, it was full of avoidance. At that time, neither of them wanted to pop the bubble they were hiding in. Which ultimately made them live in a fantasy—but here there were no false illusions. They had laid themselves bare and it was a level of raw intimacy Izuku had never experienced.

And from the sound of it, Katsuki shared his sentiments.

“I feel like I can talk to you about anything,” Katsuki muttered suddenly. He leaned across the candle lit table and rested his head against his hand. “I don’t know why I said that, but it feels true.”

“I get what you’re saying, Kacchan,” Izuku said, returning the sentiment. “I also feel like I can talk to you about anything. It’s really nice, right?”

Katsuki hummed as he took his hand. “It is. This is so corny, but I always knew you were someone special to me, but now I feel like you are my person.”

“I feel like you’re my person too.”

ᔓᔓᔓ

On their next official date, Katsuki had taken him to the Apple Picking room. There were no real apples in this room, the walls were just painted like they were. On the shelves were bath bombs that were shaped like apples, and they were all decorated with cute, tiny green ribbons.

During this date Izuku felt them finally solidify. Like concrete hardening after being laid down, their bond had strengthened and in return, so did their connection. They were becoming deeply in tune with each other.

It was this day Katsuki was grieving his mother more than the previous days. Katsuki hadn’t said it outright, but Izuku could tell. Of course, Izuku had sensed it before, but today he could see it clearly. The sag in Katsuki’s shoulders was like there were weights tied to him and his responses were slightly off like he wasn’t fully paying attention.

His husband was clearly in his head, and Izuku knew it could only really be about one thing.

In the middle of their date, Izuku spoke up.

“You’re feeling sad today, aren’t you?” Izuku asked.

Katsuki didn’t seem surprised or try to deny it.

“Yeah,” Katsuki whispered. “I, uh, woke up feeling more sluggish today. I’m not sure why, but I missed my mom this morning. It’s stupid I know.”

“It’s not stupid,” Izuku eased. He grabbed Katsuki’s hand and stood up. “Let me show you something.”

Katsuki let himself be led.

They walked out of the Apple room and went to their bedroom. Izuku grabbed a blanket and then they both put their jackets on. Izuku zipped Katsuki’s up tight and wrapped the newly bought scarf around his neck and face.

They headed straight upstairs for the rooftop hand in hand.

Izuku laid out the blanket on the rooftop and they laid down on it together.

The fog had lifted progressively over these days, giving way to a crystal-clear sky above. Every star was in view and the full moon was shining down on them.

“Try counting the stars and think about your mom,” Izuku instructed. “It might help a little bit.”

Katsuki did. He silently counted them in his head and Izuku did too. Slowly but surely, they fell into a place of comfort as Katsuki pulled Izuku in closer for warmth. Izuku could feel Katsuki’s heartbeat slow down and his body ease.

After a long while, Katsuki let out a shaky, but relieved breath of air.

He turned to Izuku and the tenseness that was caught in his body was gone.

“Thank you,” Katsuki said quietly. “I don’t know why but that weirdly helped. How did you know to do that?”

“Hiryu sometimes would find a rooftop and we would count the stars together in silence,” Izuku explained. He held Katsuki’s hand as he rubbed circles against the soft part of his skin. “I never understood why he did that until after he died. Whenever I found myself grieving him more than usual some days, I counted the stars like this and took a moment to reflect on the life we had shared. It helped ease the pain.”

Katsuki thoughtfully looked up above. He understood what Izuku was saying and squeezed his hand.

“…I’m sorry about what happened between you and Hiryu,” Katsuki said. His voice was hoarse, and there was a trapped pain inside of it that was still working itself out. “All those times I jabbed at you about killing him in the past without knowing the full story…I know it must’ve hurt.”

“It’s okay, Kacchan,” Izuku whispered tenderly. He turned his eyes back up to the Big Dipper. “On days like this we can count the stars together if this helps. No need to rush, talk, or even think. We can count the stars until the ache in your chest eases and lay here all you like.”

“Okay. But we must make sure to do the same for you,” Katsuki corrected. “On the days you feel heavy too, we can take our time.”

Izuku smiled sadly. “I think I like the sound of that.”

They silently counted the constellations above side by side.

“You got a new freckle here, darling,” Katsuki unexpectedly whispered.

Izuku turned his head to Katsuki who was looking directly at him. His eyes were watery, but no tears fell. The way his eyes were trained on him, made Izuku realize Katsuki hadn't been counting the stars this whole time—he had been counting his freckles.

Katsuki leaned over and kissed his cheek where the new freckle was.

ᔓᔓᔓ

After a full week of dates as husbands, Izuku and Katsuki were in tune with each other on a different wavelength. It was new to Izuku to be this in sync with someone who was not from his family.

The mood in the bathhouse was different now too.

Everyone had fully lightened up and their personalities shone through the glum fog.

Nemuri and Takeyama fought like siblings, and Ryuko was as cool as a winter breeze. She handled any outbursts with ease like it was a regular day whenever her cousin and Nemuri got into a small argument. Sekijiro was as strong as a mountain but as lovable as a teddy bear. Izuku had to resist the urge to squeeze him every time he started gushing about a new dessert he made.

In this small group, Izuku was finally understanding why people were kind to each other.

He was still getting used to it, but he thinks he sort of understood it now. Being kind to those around him made him feel safe, maybe even fortified them as a unit. He trusted the other employees here and that let him sleep a little bit better at night.

But even more so, they had *fun* together.

Katsuki slammed down a card on the table with a smirk and it triggered a choir of groans. Takeyama nearly screamed in disbelief as she scrubbed her hands down her face.

"Are you *kidding* me?!" Nemuri shouted as she threw her hands up in disbelief. "No, there's no way! You're *cheating*!"

"Nope, I'm not," Katsuki replied with a diabolical chuckle. "I'm just *that* fucking good at Monopoly. Sucks to suck, extras. Now give me your property."

"This has to be some type of witchcraft," Sekijiro said seriously. He frowned deeply and over-analyzed the board that was covered in Katsuki's little red houses. "I've never seen anyone who plays this game so methodically. What makes you so driven to be this amazing at this?"

"What can I say? I like money," Katsuki smugly answered.

Everyone erupted in a laugh as Katsuki moved a piece on the game board.

Izuku watched the game progress happily as he shifted himself on Katsuki's lap. There weren't enough seats in the living room area, but Izuku didn't find it weird to sit on Katsuki's leg like this in front of everyone. They all didn't seem to mind either as they were far too engrossed in the game.

His husband tightened his one-armed hold on him in the commotion as he started yapping off to Nemuri in another cocky rant. When Izuku adjusted again Katsuki turned and looked at him.

"Are you comfortable?" Katsuki asked.

Izuku nodded happily. "Of course. Are you comfortable?"

"I got the cutest damn guy in the world on my lap and I'm whipping everyone's ass at monopoly, of course I'm comfortable."

Katsuki grinned wide and playfully bounced Izuku on his leg. Izuku laughed and leaned into his husband to give him a small kiss. A rise of whistles erupted from in front of them and Izuku grew a little bit shy but buzzed with happiness.

It was nice being around people who supported him and Katsuki. He never knew that was something he wanted until now.

As the game of Monopoly continued, it resulted in Katsuki winning it all—which surprised no one.

They all began to clean up the mess they had made from hanging out after hours. Once the game was put away, it was here Izuku and Katsuki noted that they were the only ones still in their uniforms.

"Oi, what are you all dressed up for?" Katsuki asked.

"Oh! There's going to be fireworks tonight in town," Takeyama said with a wide grin. "It was short notice but nearly everyone is heading down to the port area to watch."

Izuku tilted his head. "What's the occasion?"

"None, really," Ryuko replied. She shrugged her shoulders with a gentle, graceful smile. "The mayor is feeling better, and he wants to do something to lighten the spirits of the town. Fireworks before it gets too cold is the perfect thing."

"You two should join us!" Sekijiro urged. "You've been holed up in the bathhouse for a whole two weeks."

"Hey, I said no pushing them," Nemuri snapped quickly. "They can stay inside if they want to."

Both Izuku and Katsuki grew quiet at that.

They hadn't stepped foot outside longer than to take the trash out since the lantern festival. While fresh air would've been nice, they were both growing more and more paranoid. Izuku kept the twin blades hidden in the back of his sash now and Katsuki also did the same. His husband strapped a gun on his body with his chest holster that was hidden inside his uniform.

The heightened paranoia was mainly because they were finally back at a good place. It was very easy to see what they had to lose now. And risking that all by going outside didn't seem worth it.

"Fireworks do sound nice," Izuku mused then he gave a sheepish smile. "But it's okay. Kacchan and I will stay inside. We don't mind it here, really. The place is big enough to feel like its own world."

"Agreed," Katsuki said simply. "We'll be okay."

"Hey," Nemuri said. She walked up to them and put a reassuring hand on Izuku's shoulder. "If you want, you can sort of see the fireworks from the sauna room. The large window there is pointed at the ocean so you can see where the fireworks are going to be."

Izuku perked up all the way.

"That's a good compromise," Izuku agreed. "Thank you, Nemuri!"

"Anytime," she replied. She nodded her head at them both. "Well, we're going to head out. When I come back, I'm going to wipe the floor with you in Uno, Katsuki. This isn't over yet."

"Hah, *sure*." Katsuki smirked. "We'll see about that. I'm the king of board games in this damn house."

ᔓᔓᔓ

Once everyone was gone, the two husbands had the quiet bathhouse all to themselves. They shut off the lights in the living area and headed up to the Sauna Room. They both sat down on the ledge of the window that jutted out. The two of them faced each other, knees lightly touching.

The window was big enough to nearly cover the whole wall, and Nemuri was right. It gave a perfect view of the sky near the sea. Izuku leaned against the window, soaking in the cool surface that contrasted the humidity in the room.

He turned his gaze to see Katsuki staring at him pensively. The emotion in his eyes was far different from the light mood they had experienced moments ago.

"Is something the matter, Kacchan?" Izuku asked.

Katsuki opened his mouth and then closed it. His brows furrowed together, and pain struck across his face.

“I’m…I’m really fucking sorry, Izuku,” Katsuki whispered. The words were as heavy as a mountain and made Izuku freeze.

“Sorry for what?” Izuku asked for clarification.

“I’m sorry for blaming you, for hunting you, and for trying to *hurt* you,” Katsuki said. “I’m so goddamn sorry.”

He shuffled in closer and Izuku was deeply taken back that this was coming up now. But Katsuki was more than serious. He took Izuku’s hand in his own and they began to shake with a monumental amount of guilt.

“My stupid ass anger blinded me,” Katsuki continued. His eyes teared up as he searched Izuku’s freckles. “I lost control and I wound up becoming something I never wanted to be—I kept…I kept *forcing* myself to hunt you despite this voice screaming in my head not to the whole time.”

“It’s okay, Kacchan. I forgive you,” Izuku said. “Between Tomura and Himiko, the situation was manipulated beyond our control. If I hadn’t listened to Tomura, Himiko wouldn’t have been able to steal my letter. I don’t blame you at all for the way you snapped.”

He tried to steady Katsuki’s hand on his own. He wanted to bring them back to the light mood they had been in.

“But you *should* blame me,” Katsuki insisted. His eyes pleaded for a lick of hate. “My temper is so fucking bad sometimes, *especially* when it comes to my mother. She’s always been the biggest trigger for my rage, and I exploded exactly like my old supervisor thought I would. And he was fucking *right*—I did take it out on someone I didn’t want to.”

Katsuki tightly grasped his hands and Izuku’s heart squeezed.

A wave of unwanted tears pushed at Izuku’s eyes. He wanted to tell his husband it was okay because he didn’t want to think too hard about what had happened.

“And Izuku—I-I almost—fuck.” A small tear rolled out of Katsuki’s eye. “I almost killed you. And then I nearly made a *really* bad fucking mistake—”

“—but you *didn’t* kill me,” Izuku said, finally speaking up.

Katsuki shook his head. “No, that’s not what I’m saying. I’m saying that I nearly—”

“—Kacchan, *please*. Listen to me,” Izuku interrupted. He waited for Katsuki to bulldoze the conversation, but his husband didn’t. Instead, Katsuki looked down into his lap like he was riddled with guilt. “Do you still want to hurt me?”

“Of course not,” Katsuki replied.

“Do you think you’re still capable of hurting me?”

“No. I could never.”

“Then we’re okay,” Izuku whispered.

He lifted a hand to wipe the lone tear from Katsuki’s cheek. His husband screwed his eyes shut in pain like his head was pounding. Katsuki tried to speak once more but Izuku shook his head and spoke first.

“What’s in the past, let’s leave it in the past,” Izuku suggested, feeling reassured. “The fact that you couldn’t go through with it despite having a *perfectly* good reason too, shows what’s inside of your heart. I mean, Katsuki. I killed your *mother*. That’s not a small thing. But even without hearing about my life, you still couldn’t kill me. T-That speaks *volumes* in my opinion. You didn’t even need to know about the letter or how I was brought up to not kill me.”

“Izuku…” Katsuki mournfully said. “I think you’re brushing this off too quickly.”

“Maybe I am,” Izuku whispered. “But we could both be caught in an endless spiral of sorrys if we’re not careful.”

He wanted nothing more than to make sure they were happy. They were so *close* to happiness that Izuku didn’t want to jinx it now.

“At the end of the day, all that matters to me is that you *couldn’t do it*,” Izuku whispered. He smiled sadly at his husband. “I tried very, *very* hard to kill you in Taiwan. B-But I couldn’t. I wanted to kill you; hell I wished you *died* in Vienna right after I left you there to bleed out.”

Katsuki shook his head. “But that’s not the same—”

“—*It is*. And if we keep punishing ourselves, we’re never going to be happy. Don’t you want to be happy together?”

“Yes…I want to be happy with you so badly.”

“Then let’s.”

It clicked then what Katsuki probably needed to hear.

“The truth is we both hurt each other, in so many ways,” Izuku said sadly. They met unwavering gazes and both looked struck with guilt. “We betrayed each other, we broke each other’s hearts. And on several occasions have shot, stabbed and, in my case, poisoned each other. But all I want now is to start over because we’re at such a good spot. We love each other so much, don’t we?”

“We do,” Katsuki agreed quietly. “I love you more than I ever thought was possible.”

“And I feel the same.” Izuku’s eyes watered. “And I know our lives are all tangled up, but we can keep apologizing forever if we keep on like this. We’re not too far from Nana now, and all I want is a clean slate. I know it’s selfish because there’s so many crimes I’ve committed, and I’m very much probably not worthy of a normal life. B-But I want it. I want to be normal, and I want to bury the past.”

“You deserve all that, Izuku,” Katsuki agreed.

“And you deserve it too, Kacchan. We can be sorry the rest of our lives or we can be happy together and try our best to leave the past in the past.”

It was a silent plea.

Izuku knew Katsuki probably wanted to talk more about the Scarlet Masquerade and the days following it. But the sad lump in Izuku’s throat didn’t. To him, looking back on it was now too painful and too much. They had been so misaligned that it was dreadful.

But at the end of the day, Katsuki couldn’t kill him, and he still offered to help him.

Izuku didn’t want to accidentally conjure the past back up by discussing it too much. He wanted new memories—warm ones that made him feel as lovely as their ‘first dates’.

“Okay,” Katsuki said, voice still laced with pain. He smiled the best he could and nodded. “Past is in the past from here on out. I forgot you can be so damn wise.”

“Only sometimes.” Izuku smiled.

“More than sometimes.”

Right on cue, the fireworks went off. They both turned their heads to see the dazzling hues of blue, red, and purple light up the night sky.

The crackling sound was loud, filling up the whole bathhouse as their world was illuminated.

Izuku watched silently. He appreciated the moment of calmness, and the joy people were finding in their own dark times. He wished that he could be like this small town: mighty and work through all his troubles. He wanted to harness their strength and come out on the other side better for it.

As the roaring fireworks continued, Katsuki squeezed his hand.

They turned to each other, appreciating the way the other one’s skin lit up with the varying colors.

“I love you, Izuku,” Katsuki said.

“I love you too, Kacchan,” Izuku replied.

Forgiveness was a funny thing, Izuku realized. It had the power to mend, but also the power to transform someone completely. They both had forgiven each other, and the strength that gave them allowed them to overcome the mountain that was between them.

The pull inside of Izuku’s chest told him to lean in. He did so slowly and went for a kiss. Katsuki saw this, and he leaned in too. The hammering in his chest as they drew near told him this was *it*. This was something more than passion. More than acceptance or love.

This felt like—

The singing of metal cut through the air. Both Izuku and Katsuki stopped, right before their lips touched as a sharp knife sliced between them, right where their kiss would have connected. The star knife sank into the window between them, nearly shattering it with countless little cracks spreading all over the glass.

Both of their heads whipped towards the entrance and all the hairs on Izuku's body stood up.

"Well, isn't this *heartwarming*?" Himiko hissed.

Izuku's breath caught as she walked into the room all the way. Behind her was nothing but pitch-black darkness and in her eyes was the same. The usual spark of mischief or sick delight that was inside of her blood-colored eyes was gone.

Nothing but the pure intent of homicide could be found.

Panic shot through Izuku's veins.

"Katsuki," Izuku harshly whispered as he began reaching for his knives in the back of his sash. "That's *Himiko*."

His killer instincts flipped on, and so did Katsuki's.

Deadly scarlet and viridian eyes both restricted down at the same time. The temperature in the air began chilling as the colors from the fireworks flashed on and off through the large window.

Katsuki stood up slowly and Izuku began to do the same.

The air shifted as Himiko scowled at them like they were nothing but worms in her life. She took an offensive stance and began readying her weapon of choice that was a long chain with a blade melded to either end. Along her arms were rows of daggers and star knives decorating her bright red body suit.

Carefully, all three assassins assessed each other's movements. The ticking down on the clock above felt like grains of sand as Katsuki took an offensive stance as well.

Izuku shuffled in closer to Katsuki and his heart began hammering at how quickly their rest time was up. He knew two on one should likely work in their favor, but Himiko was a force of nature worth an army. Even going toe to toe with her would be difficult with the two of them.

In an attempt to draw first blood, Katsuki quickly reached for his gun.

But the sound of a second pistol cocking made him freeze.

Both Izuku and Katsuki cut their eyes to the side entrance. Another set of footsteps approached them from there. Heavy thud after thud came, and Izuku's eyes widened with

each step. He *recognized* those footsteps. His heart dropped to the lowest pits of hell and the tall figure came into light.

It felt impossible.

“Aw, don’t look so surprised, baby bro,” Jin chuckled cruelly. “You didn’t think The Double Headed Viper would go down that easily, did you?”

Chapter End Notes

Aaaannnd we're back into the frying pan :^D *hides* Thank you so much for reading and commenting! Let me know what you think below :)

Chapter 33: Consonance

Chapter Summary

Consonance (tempo modifier) agreement and harmony among musical notes.

Izuku and Katsuki work in harmony, but they are not the only ones.

Chapter Notes

Hellooo!!! Welcome back to this choo choo train of angst! First, so so sorry for the lateness on this chapter. I had hit a small wall with this chapter because I was struggling to find myself to write it to my liking. I found myself re-structing, re-writing over and over. I pretty much did this until I was satisfied :') I like it now after many revisions and Luna, out Beta angel, has reassured me it's good to go.

I got a bit fixated on it and found myself without time to replay to comments. But I am doing so now! I hope you enjoy!! I am very nervous now, but I might been over thinking it.

Without further wait, I present to you everyone's favorite lethal lovers!

Warnings: Character Death, Minor Character Death, Graphic Depictions of Violence and Excessive blood.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 33 — Consonance

.

.

.

Izuku could hear his heartbeat. His vision pulsed with every step Jin took forward.

Like the dawn of a sun he never hoped to see, Izuku comprehended he hadn’t finished the job. Every single berating Tomura had ever given him about sloppy work pounded against his skull. Instantly, he hated himself.

Tomura always taught him to double tap a close-range gunshot kill. It was important to make sure a vital artery was severed. His Big Brother emphasized this because there was always the tiniest chance that someone could survive a gunshot. Solely because a bullet could be off a single millimeter from lethality.

And now, like a real ghost, Jin was back to haunt him as the embodiment of his sloppiness.

His elder brother was wearing bandages everywhere. There was a bloodied one covering his left eye. It stretched across his whole head and Izuku could see where he went wrong. Both of Jin's arms were wrapped up too. But there were no slings or stents to help the fractured bones stay in place. Jin walked as if he wasn't injured at all.

But when he came closer, Izuku sensed something about Jin was off.

His brother seemed slightly unbalanced. It was as if he was keeping himself upright with effort. It was here that Izuku noticed Jin fight off a small limp. His unnerving smile fell for a moment to show a split-second indication of frustration.

Immediately, Katsuki noted it too. He gripped his gun tighter.

It was now evident Jin was weakened from the previous assault. But Izuku drew the rapid conclusion that his brother was likely pumped up on an obscene number of painkillers and pure spite.

"What? You're not going to greet your dear ol' brother and sister after we've come all this way?" Jin taunted. "Especially because you left home in complete fucking disarray. Hell, you could at least apologize for killing Ibara and Aoyama like they were goddamn *animals*—and trying to kill me."

An arrow of guilt pierced through Izuku.

"You all gave me no choice," Izuku hissed.

"There's always a goddamn choice," Jin snapped. "And the choice you made is protecting some snot nosed brats and this outsider over us." He glared at Katsuki. "But I'm sure that's just your M.O. by now. You shot me in my beautiful face and then stole my katana? What a fucking good way to piss me off."

This was bad.

He looked over to Katsuki who was clenching his jaw—he knew it was bad too.

Two on two was always tricky.

Over his shoulder, Katsuki wearily glanced at him and Izuku glanced back. Katsuki's gun was still aimed at Himiko, but his sister was being eerily quiet. She assessed Katsuki carefully and tightened her grip on the chain in her hand. Her eyes then glided around, studying the room.

Her calculating stare lingered on the broken sauna gauge on the side of the Amethyst Sauna.

“Please, let us go,” Izuku attempted to reason. “We’re going to be leaving, and I promise you we’ll be out of your lives forever.”

“I think you’ve forgotten who Tomura *is*.” Jin scoffed, pointed at Katsuki, and said, “And by the way, Chisaki wants you buried six feet deep.” He then pointed his finger at Izuku. “And he wants you to come back with us to Tokyo. Fortunately for you, Chisaki decided he still wants his green-eyed prize.”

Unexpectedly, Himiko laughed. A small slip of maniacal chuckles spilled into the air as she shook her head.

She sunk her envious gaze into Izuku.

“Once again, you somehow lucked out, Izuku,” Himiko jeered. Her humorless laughter died, and her eyes sank deeper into hatred. “Tomura is such a damn persuasive person, isn’t he? It took him nothing but two weeks to convince Chisaki to change his mind.”

“Yup,” Jin sourly agreed. “You did have a helping hand though. That bastard basically got a hard-on right there after hearing that you killed over twenty of your own and two of the Viper Seven. You gave him exactly what he wanted: a family member for a family member—and *more*.”

“The sick fuck was delighted,” Himiko said bitterly. “But I suppose that’s what’ll make you two a good match, huh?”

The mere thought of giving Chisaki joy nearly made Izuku vomit.

He had hoped his actions that night had sown discord between the Vipers and Yakuza. All he wanted was to effectively prevent Tomura’s rise to total power. But if what Jin and Himiko were saying was true, it had the opposite effect. He could see Chisaki’s sick smile and hear his eerie laugh.

Katsuki cocked his gun and his frown deepened. “You two are doing a lot of goddamn talking.”

“Yeah, I suppose we are.” Jin sighed and tilted his head. “So. Which way are we doing this, Izuku? The easy way or are we going to have to drag you by that pretty hair of yours all the way back to Tokyo?”

“There’s not a damn chance I’m coming with you,” Izuku spat.

“Ouch! Mr. Viper Killer has got bite now,” Jin laughed. His unnerving smile widened and his one good eye steeped in blood lust. “*Good*. I was hoping we would do this the hard way.”

Instantly, both Izuku and Katsuki moved into action. Katsuki rushed towards Jin and Izuku sprinted towards Himiko.

Himiko spun backwards on her feet, and her chain moved like a deathly ribbon with her flow. She gained unnerving momentum and slung the long weapon at Izuku’s legs.

Izuku moved slightly quicker. He tilted his body out of harm's way by mere inches and didn't stop his run forward. Izuku's body pumped more adrenaline into his blood when Himiko rapidly pulled the chain back to her to fling another blow—but Izuku dodged it.

He worked quickly and grabbed on to the chain, gripping it tight around his arm. His feet slid against the ground, and he gritted his teeth. He violently pulled it towards him and Himiko staggered forward.

But his sister caught her weight.

Himiko's wild eyes filled with venom.

The chain strung taut, and they were caught in an equal test of strength. Izuku made a rapid size up: they were nearly the same in speed and strength, but Himiko possessed more accuracy in distance techniques while Izuku was better at closer combat.

Then the sudden sound of gunshots fired into the air. Izuku snapped his head to the side and his heart nearly stopped.

Katsuki was going on the offense. His husband was caught in the heat of battle, trying to land a hit on Jin as he dodged around Jin's sharp swings of the katana. Burning scarlet eyes were sharp and Katsuki's gun was firing off with frightening accuracy that would've instantly killed any man.

But Jin was not simply any man.

The Double Headed Viper had elusive skills for evasive techniques. Jin dodged every lethal bullet as if it phased through his body. The two men moved around each other like two tornadoes at close distance, clashing at high speeds.

For every bullet Katsuki tried to land, Jin used his katana to deflect. He even sliced several in two.

Then Jin landed a blow and carved shallowly through Katsuki's upper arm.

The howl of pain that bounced off the walls made Izuku freeze.

Suddenly, Izuku was harshly jerked. He stumbled forward, accidentally letting himself be distracted.

Himiko didn't waste time. She briskly twirled, wrapping her chain around her body and yanked Izuku close to her.

The other end of the chain slung around.

Izuku barely had time to dodge. It came straight for his head. Izuku ducked, and a lock of his hair was cut off. He let go of the chain and quickly fell backwards on the defensive.

That was all she needed.

Himiko began her lethal routine. She spun like a king cobra and the chain worked as an extension of her will. She whirled her body to make the heavy chain rain down thud after thud in rapid succession. The sharp blades on the end flung towards Izuku like metal fangs, and each time they bit him.

He tried to outmaneuver her the best he could. But he couldn't dodge every attack. Many shallow cuts landed on his skin like a thousand paper cuts. He hissed as his body began to feel like it was on fire. He tried harder to dodge, but the distance between them was growing too wide.

She didn't let up. Himiko gained speed. Her dance was a spiteful ballet that didn't allow Izuku to breathe. Her hateful leer grew deeper and deeper with every blood droplet of Izuku's that hit the floor.

Izuku focused all his efforts and drowned out the sound of bullets whizzing in the background to bum rush Himiko. He ducked, sidestepped, and rolled until he got close to her again. The fury in his eyes tripled as he closed the distance. He pushed through all the stinging pain across his body to finally gain the advantage.

Himiko quickly tried to back up, but Izuku didn't allow her.

He drew his blades from his sash at the highest speed and cut upwards.

Himiko yelped in pain as he sliced her arm. She stepped back. Quickly, Himiko switched gears. She went on the defensive as Izuku went on offense.

Izuku poured down strike after strike.

He only went for the kill. The jugular. The head. The neck. The heart.

But Himiko used her chain like a shield. She protected herself from his wrath and matched his expert footing. She backed up and gained an advantage briefly, and then Izuku drew close and took it back. They did this again. Then again. And again.

Soon they found themselves caught in a twin serpent dance.

They began to snake around each other at an impossible speed. They fought toe to toe, fully rivaled in their skills. They knew each other's every move. Every attempt to kill. When Himiko went high, Izuku knew to go low. When Izuku faked left, Himiko knew to dodge right.

All the years of distrust proved to deadlock them. They had been watching the other too closely, memorizing the other's moves. All the years of disdain was coming to a peak in a flurry of blades, kicks, and punches.

Izuku attempted one more blow to the head and Himiko's breath caught.

She wrapped her chain around both of his blades and strung it tight. She locked him there and Izuku's nose flared. He pushed forward with all his strength. The force he used made them go

toppling downwards to the ground. Himiko cursed but held her gridlock around his blades. Izuku pinned her down to the ground with his legs as he used all his body weight to lean in.

They were caught there and their eyes locked.

Izuku's blade was aligned perfectly with her skull.

If Himiko slipped for a moment, the points would go crashing through her forehead.

He pushed down harder but Himiko's strength held his weapons suspended in the air.

Progressively, Izuku's eyes became filled with untamable fire. He wanted to break the chain. Snap it in two and sink his obsidian blades right through his sister's skull. But he was unable to do that. As of now, Himiko's wrath was mightier than usual, and she matched his fire with her need for retribution.

The poison between them surged.

Then the sound of Jin falling to the ground snapped both of their heads to the side.

Katsuki was at an advantage now. He had disarmed Jin of his katana and knocked it to the ground. Katsuki clicked the trigger of his gun. But it came out empty—he was officially out of bullets. Quickly, he pistol-whipped Jin directly in his injured skull to keep him down.

However, Jin devoured the pain like it was nothing. In a flurry, Jin disarmed Katsuki of the gun.

Soon, the two of them began to fight. Like giant titans quaking the ground, the two men began a toe-to-toe match of their own. Jin utilized a flurry of martial arts and Katsuki held his ground by pure strength alone.

But it was clear they too were caught in a deadlock as well. Katsuki was strong. However, Jin was equally as strong. Even with fractured arms, Jin's Viper made him push through it as if he had no broken bones at all. Pain was merely fuel for them, and the more agony Jin was in, the harder he fought.

But in the same vein, the killer inside of Katsuki was forged of protective rage. And all it took was a single glance back at Izuku for Katsuki to begin fighting harsher.

Himiko's eyes snaked towards Katsuki. Then they slithered back to Izuku.

She picked up on Izuku's fear like a shark smelling iron in the water.

Desperation took a hold of Izuku. He screamed out a yell of effort. He used all his strength to push down on the chain. The metal strung tighter and Himiko's arms began to shake as she gave into his power. Izuku's eyes turned wild as a surge of fierceness quaked through his body.

The point of his blade was a mere inch away from Himiko's face now.

It took half a second for the most sickening smirk to spread across her red lips.

She stopped resisting. The chain gave, and Izuku fell forward. He stabbed to where her skull was, but she moved faster. Himiko snapped her head to the side, and the blades sank a millimeter away from her ear. She swung her chain around his neck and pulled.

Blistering pain shot all over as their heads collided.

Izuku became disoriented. And in the blur, she kicked him off. Now, she was barreling full speed towards Katsuki.

“Kacchan!” Izuku screamed as he took off full speed behind her.

It was almost too late.

Katsuki turned his head at the sound of his name. Straightaway Jin took the opening. He landed a sickening kick in Katsuki’s jaw. Katsuki hissed and ate the hit and he steeled himself.

Himiko speared her chain directly at his heart.

Katsuki rapidly moved out of the way as the blade sliced straight through the fabric of his uniform. Without hesitation, he quickly grabbed the chain with both hands. Using his whole weight, Katsuki heaved.

Himiko flew forward.

Katsuki dug his feet into the ground and flung her straight into Jin like a ball and chain. Their bodies crashed into each other unexpectedly, taking them off guard.

Himiko rapidly recovered, but Jin took two seconds longer. And that small opening was all Izuku needed. She tried again to attack Katsuki, but Izuku stopped her. He dipped low, and with the edge of his blade he cut it through her side. She screamed out. He spun on his heels to immediately send a ferocious dropkick directly to her head.

The sound of cracking bone echoed into the room. She was sent skidding straight down into the ground.

Jin readied himself to land an unexpected punch to the back of Izuku’s head. But he was stopped. Katsuki shot a handout and caught Jin’s fist in the air. He gripped it so tight he nearly broke Jin’s knuckles. Izuku rounded quickly. He ducked underneath Katsuki’s arm and landed a devastating blow with his blades.

He cut straight through the skin and muscles of one of Jin’s arms.

Jin screamed and jerked backwards. He freed himself of Izuku’s blades as they hit down to the bone.

The blood from the injury sprayed directly across Izuku and Katsuki. Jin slapped a hand over his wound and Himiko quickly recovered back on her feet. All four of them took defensive

stances.

Heavy panting filled the air as they sized each other up.

Without taking his eyes off his bloodthirsty family, Izuku handed Katsuki one of his blades. Katsuki viciously gripped the hilt. He adjusted it, slicing through the air with a twirl of his wrist. The obsidian weapon melted into an extension of his limb.

They took a step closer to each other.

Jin's teeth were clenched and Himiko worked her nearly broken jaw. The fury in her eyes escalated as she looked down to her side wound. As the blood seeped out, Izuku could feel her anger kick up another notch. She wiped her bloody nose, smearing the red liquid.

An eerie smirk spread across her lips.

"Focus your efforts to kill the brute," Himiko growled. "Izuku deserves to watch him die."

Everyone moved at the same time.

In a silent understanding, Izuku kept his eye on Jin while Katsuki kept his eye on Himiko. They found themselves in a wordless sync as they combined their strength and speed.

Whenever Himiko tried to lock her chain around Izuku's neck, Katsuki would quickly catch it and overpower her. When Jin tried to stab Katsuki in the side, Izuku quickly out moved him and disarmed him with speed Jin didn't possess.

They kept on the defensive and found themselves using the other for leverage. Jin swung a punch in Katsuki's direction. Katsuki ducked low to dodge. In the same moment Izuku kicked high above Katsuki and landed a successful swift combo to Jin's face. Katsuki spun low and then slung his blade into Himiko with his whole-body weight.

It didn't take long before they were fighting back-to-back, covering the other.

It went on like this until Izuku felt fire ignite in his lungs. The fury of kicks, punches and blades was proving to make both Jin and Himiko frustrated. Izuku could feel the despondency spill into the air. Together, he and Katsuki were impenetrable. And it seemed like both his siblings were picking up on that fact.

Then Izuku caught the split-second look exchanged between Jin and Himiko. They nodded and began to switch up their attacks.

Jin suddenly turned and ran away from the heat of battle. He headed straight towards his katana.

Without hesitation, Izuku took off after him. He knew he could outrun him. But in the next second, Himiko wrapped her chain around Katsuki like a snake.

She tangled him up in her metal web and yanked him across the other side of the room.

Through his shaky vision, Izuku could see a blur of blond.

Himiko and Katsuki immediately began combat and it was incredibly fast paced. Himiko successfully cut Katsuki's calf. Katsuki then sliced her shoulder. They both fought through the pain inflicted, but it was clear Katsuki couldn't predict Himiko like Izuku could.

Himiko's mixed aerobatic techniques were something Katsuki had never faced.

Izuku hesitated for a split second. He wanted to help—but then pushed forward.

He kicked his feet higher in gear to pass Jin. The two brothers caught gazes. They both looked at the katana. It all suddenly felt slow. Jin dived for the blade, and Izuku slid on the ground.

Within the blink of an eye, Izuku's hand reached the hilt first.

He grabbed the katana the second before Jin could. Jin tried to drop backwards, but Izuku whipped the sword wide.

The sharp blade cut straight through Jin's stomach.

Blood sprayed across Izuku and the floor. Jin choked. He stumbled on his feet and Izuku lunged for the kill. His nostrils flared as oxygen rolled through his body. Pure, unfiltered adrenaline drove him as he plunged forward. He sank the katana straight through Jin's center.

Both of their eyes went wide.

Jin grabbed the blade out of shock and stared into Izuku's eyes.

Izuku's heart skipped a beat.

"Damn." Jin gave an impressed, bloodied smile. A trail of red spilled from both sides of his lips as he tried to laugh. He tilted his head. "You came a long way from being the runt, huh? And here I thought we were starting to feel like whatever a 'family' is."

Guilt pulsed through Izuku. He blinked back conflicting tears.

He pushed the blade in deeper until it pierced through the other side. Jin gasped as he tried to scramble for something in his pocket. It was a syringe filled with paralyzer. Jin weakly attempted to stab it at Izuku's neck, but Izuku caught his wrist without much effort.

He gazed up at his elder brother who was now coughing up blood.

Izuku twisted the blade until he knew it hurt.

"We were nothing like a family," Izuku said wretchedly.

Jin laughed. He shook his head and whispered, "To me, we were."

Izuku cut up, severing the organs inside of his brother. Blood pooled at their feet as Jin dropped to his knees. Izuku kneeled with him, keeping his hand on the hilt of the blade. He watched as Jin fought against death. His brother strained to keep his eyes open and he weakly hold up the syringe. Once more, he tried to stab at Izuku's neck, but darkness pulled him under this time.

Jin blinked once. Then twice. Then he closed his eyes and slumped over on the ground.

The syringe full of blue liquid rolled across the wooden floor.

A shrill scream cut through the air.

"*No*!" Himiko shrieked.

Izuku whirled his head towards the other side of the room.

Himiko's face was distorted in horror. Tears collected at the rims of her eyes as she watched Jin's body twitch. Her gaze filled with terrifying spite as she dodged another one of Katsuki's blows.

The murder brimming inside of her became a terrifying aura. Waves of red pulsed from her frame. She gritted her teeth and Izuku could see her relive Sen's death. She whirled on Katsuki at the same time Izuku dropped the hilt of the katana.

Izuku sprinted to the other side of the room. Himiko's speed kicked up a gear.

She moved like vengeful lightning.

There was no time to move out of the way. Katsuki was instantly tangled tightly in her chain. It wrapped around him like a deadly python and his arms became painfully restricted at his sides. Katsuki tried to struggle out. But before he could, Himiko delivered several hate-filled punches to his jaw.

A sickening crack of broken bone echoed out.

Right as Izuku was about to reach them, suddenly a body collided with him.

His whole world view toppled upside down as he was tackled to the ground. Izuku yelled when he was rolled over and violently stabbed in the neck with the point of a needle. He howled in pain.

When he finally got a clear view, Jin was above him on his last breath. Through a sickening smile, blood poured out of his mouth and onto Izuku.

"Sorry," Jin wheezed. He heaved, ready to pass out at any given moment. "Even if it's the last thing I do, you're going to go back home one way or another, *baby brother*."

The paralyzer was fast working. He could feel his body fight against it. But his immunity was not at the peak of its abilities after two weeks of missing micro-dosing himself. In a haze, all Izuku's senses decelerated. His limbs became shaky, and he was unable to push Jin off.

Jin gave one last uncanny grin before his eyes rolled back. He fell on to Izuku face forward with a heavy thud. The dead weight made Izuku nearly scream out as all his wounds were pressed on to. But he pushed through his weakened state the best he could. However, it was difficult. He was slowly falling more and more into a stupor.

Black began to swim at the edges of his vision. A small whimper escaped his lips.

The sound of Izuku's weakened gasp made Katsuki whip his head.

And in that split second where his eyes were not on Himiko, he made a tragic mistake. A flying kick connected with his chest. He was knocked straight over—and right into the Amethyst Room. His back cracked as he slammed into the hard wall inside.

The bone breaking sound made Izuku crane his neck.

Through his dimmed vision, Izuku saw Katsuki inside of the broken sauna. His husband freed himself from the chain—but Himiko reeled it back like a whip. She struck him across the face with it without mercy. Katsuki's blood splattered across the inside of the room as he fell to the side.

In the blink of an eye, Himiko slammed the glass doors shut.

She quickly tied the handles together with her chain, locking the doors together.

Himiko wasted no time turning the sauna up to a lethal boil. She broke the gauge with her elbow for good measure and the glass scattered across the ground.

Katsuki worked himself up right again. He exhaled heavily as he held his face and violently shoved on the doors to get out. However, all he got in return was a horrific rattle. He shoved again and again, and the chain sang its metallic tune. It wasn't budging.

Izuku's heart stopped. Himiko trapped Katsuki inside.

The red lights inside the sauna snapped on and the buzzing of heat sizzled into the air.

Katsuki began punching the glass with his inhuman strength, but it didn't break. Izuku made the quick conclusion that it was plexiglass. And unless Katsuki suddenly had the strength of 10,000 pounds in a single punch, he wasn't going to make it out on his own.

The red lights inside the sauna turned a deeper shade.

Katsuki looked up, horrified. He began punching harder until his knuckles bled.

Izuku screamed out for him. The urgency of Katsuki in danger made everything speed up. He overpowered his shaking limbs to push Jin's limp body off him. He whipped up on his feet and took off with energy he didn't have.

Expectedly, he was stopped by a swift kick from Himiko. Izuku blocked with his arms and whirled on his feet. He countered with an equally lethal kick to the back of her head. But of course, she blocked exactly like him with a low duck.

With half dim vision, Izuku began to fight Himiko with everything he had. Every second he could feel against his skin. The pounding of Katsuki trying to break the glass kept on in the background. It was a horrible percussion keeping tempo to the rhythm of their fight.

Himiko hit him in the jaw. Izuku stabbed her in the leg. She clawed her nails down his face, and he dropped the point of his elbow into her mouth. She lost a tooth and spit it in his face. He lost his composure and tried to wrap his hands around her throat. They fell to the ground in a furious squabble.

Desperation took a hold of them both. Within mere seconds, their movements became more and more unraveled. Izuku and Himiko twisted up together like vipers in a final showdown. It was now evident that this was the moment.

All the years of hatred between them was coming to a boiling point.

Izuku gritted his teeth as he was slammed onto his back. Himiko lunged for him with a knife, and Izuku caught her wrists.

The tip of her blade was an inch away from his eye.

Izuku's arms began to shake as she pushed down, determined to drive it through his skull. Their gazes locked and fearsome electricity surged through the air. Izuku's heart was beating erratically as he heard Katsuki in the background beginning to scream from the heat that was ticking up and up.

Himiko pushed down harder, nearly overpowering him.

The point of the knife got a half an inch away from his eye.

"I'm going to rejoice when I finally *kill* you," Himiko proclaimed venomously. "I never had any goddamn plans of bringing you back to Tomura alive. You don't *deserve* a happy ending."

Those last two words made Izuku envision the happy ending he wanted.

He saw Katsuki, their future house, and all the love they had promised each other. Something unlocked inside of him more powerful than his instinct to survive. It was warm, and it was fearsome. It combined with all his violent tendencies and gifted him a second surge of strength. He felt his veins pulse under his skin.

The paralyzer in his body suddenly felt as thin as water. His vision slowly came back, and he could see crystal clear all the things in life he wanted—and it was Katsuki.

Izuku decided she was wrong. He deserved his happy ending.

With a fearsome yell, Izuku twisted Himiko's wrist around. She balked at his sudden wave of power and before she could act, the point of her blade faced her.

Izuku thrusted it directly into her eye.

An ear shattering scream overshadowed the squelch. Izuku's face twisted in sheer malice as he pushed the blade deeper and then cut wide.

He sprung up to his feet as his sister screamed on the ground.

Himiko grappled at her face, blood seeping between her fingertips. She cursed his name and tried to dive at him but missed. Izuku side stepped and immediately stabbed right into the other eye, blinding her fully. She fell to her knees, screeching his name like a curse to the sky.

Izuku promptly set off towards the sauna.

Inside was Katsuki, sweating profusely and hissing as he no longer could touch the door. Blisters were swelling on his legs as he nearly cooked alive.

Izuku whipped off the chains from the door and flung them open.

Katsuki rolled out of the cooker immediately. He flung himself to the cold ground and sucked in a breath between his teeth. Izuku squatted down to catch him and held him in his arms. Katsuki gripped back, gasping for sweet, cold air as his body shook. Both of their eyes were wide with horror at what nearly was too late.

A sudden faithful cry ripped beside them.

Both Izuku and Katsuki snapped their heads to see Himiko charging for them. Blood cascaded down her cheeks from her butchered eyes as she lunged. But Izuku rushed her right back. They collided, and this time, he was able to finally have the upper hand.

She blindly flung a knife and Izuku grabbed her arm. He tossed her around, and with all his strength threw her into the sauna. He picked up the chain before she could get up again and wrapped it tightly around the door handles. Exactly like she had done.

Himiko flew forward.

She screamed and banged on the glass. It rattled underneath her tremendous rage. She yelled loudly as the temperature inside began to boil. Her fists pounded harder and harder. She did what Katsuki couldn't, and the glass mildly cracked under her fist.

But it gave no more. It kept her trapped inside as she yelled Izuku's name.

"You fucking runt!" Himiko screamed. She progressively became more and more undone, blinded by her rage and now by Izuku's brutality. "Let me out of here! This is not fair! It's not fair, it's not fair!"

Izuku took a large step back and his hands began to shake. He stared into her face, and it was like looking into a twisted mirror. Countless lines of blood streamed down her face, and her hair was tousled in every direction. Her lipstick had smeared across her skin and countless cuts and bruises were all along her jaw.

She looked like The Blood Viper, doused in its own undoing.

“Why…Why do you get to be happy?!” Himiko demanded fiercely. She scraped her nails along the glass, and both Izuku and Katsuki recoiled at the high-pitched sound. Then slowly, her screams devolved into sobs. Helpful, terrified sobs. “Why did you get to be special, Izuku? Why?! Why did I get the shittest life?!”

He wished he had the answers. But he didn’t.

Because he wasn’t special. And he didn’t always get happiness. Their hell was crafted from the same pain, but she always assumed the knife was duller on his side. But Izuku knew the truth, the knife that cut them was always the same type of sharp. It simply cut them in different ways.

Slowly, Izuku walked up to the glass.

He studied her mangled face. The cuts, the bruises. The blood red hue that was splattered all over her. Without flinching, he took one last good look at his sister—his rival. He saw his reflection in the glass stack on top of her.

Izuku leaned in as Himiko began to cry blood.

“At least you will know the last thing you and Sen both saw before you died was my face,” Izuku venomously whispered. “You can talk about how you both hated me in hell.”

A scream as vicious as a storm erupted.

Himiko drove deeper into her hatred. She yelled his name. She cursed his future. She cracked the glass some more, and for a moment, Izuku wondered if it would give in to her unbridled strength. But it didn’t. It kept her solidly confined, just like all the envy she harbored for Izuku.

She could do nothing but helplessly scream as her skin began to boil.

Blisters the size of coins began to rise on her flesh. She fought against it, scraping them off like pimples. Blood spilled and more blisters appeared. She frantically rattled the doors as the lights inside turned the deepest shade of blood red. Then the lights flickered. The sound of the heat buzzing was at its highest octave, and it mimicked a swarm of wasps.

And then Himiko stopped.

Her blind gaze looked forward as if seeing him. With finality, she accepted her last moments.

Izuku froze. He watched with a conflicting heavy heart.

Katsuki limped towards him. He stopped beside Izuku and watched with a horrified expression as she cooked alive. Swiftly, Katsuki turned his gaze away. He shook his head and put a hand on Izuku’s shoulder.

“You don’t have to watch this,” Katsuki murmured.

But Izuku didn't budge. He kept his eyes tethered to Himiko. Because even though they hated each other, she deserved to have a witness to her undoing.

"Yes, I do," Izuku whispered.

She smiled at him, for the first time. She laughed and then finally she slumped down.

Then she whispered her last words: "I hope you never find happiness, Izuku."

It felt like her final strike. And this promise cut into him more than any of the blows she had landed before. Himiko faded and her body went deathly still on the ground. However, behind she left her rage. Her words rang as if there was truth inside of them.

And exactly like she wanted, Izuku wondered if she was right.

Weary green eyes looked around.

Surrounding them was a sea of blood.

It was everywhere. On the walls, on the ceiling, the floors. It was on the doors and in cracks. He gazed at the two mutilated bodies of his siblings and soon their ghosts were added to his endless catalog. He could feel their eternal eyes stare up at him and their spiteful simpers were stapled to the inside of his thoughts.

Izuku wondered if she was right.

Was this forever going to be his life? Would he ever *really* find happiness? Even if they escaped now, how long would it be before Tomura sent another viper after them? And then another and another? Not to mention the Yakuza. Was he forever doomed to a life of endless death?

As if Katsuki could see him drowning in his mind, he shook Izuku out of it. He grabbed Izuku by his shoulders and lightly jolted him.

The sudden movement jerked Izuku back into the present. He focused his gaze and stared up at the love of his life.

"Hey, breathe," Katsuki desperately urged. "We need to *go*."

Izuku swallowed dryly and took a deep inhale. He hadn't even registered that he had stopped breathing. He shakily exhaled and nodded. Pushing back the haunting thoughts, he glanced around. His eyes cut towards Himiko and Jin's unnervingly still bodies.

They could no longer afford sloppiness.

"We need to cut their jugulars," Izuku instructed seriously. "We have to make sure they're dead and bleed them out."

"Good idea," Katsuki agreed.

Together they walked over to Jin's body first. Katsuki kicked him over and Izuku took the katana out of Jin's abdomen. Without flinching, Katsuki bent down and craned Jin's neck for Izuku. He angled it well, showing the slight raise of the vein under the skin.

They looked at each other once as Izuku steadied his shaking hands.

He put the edge of the blade to the crook and slit Jin's neck open.



They both quickly ran into the hallway.

Izuku was gripping his twin blades. Katsuki was wielding Jin's gun. He was carefully counting the rounds left and he held up three fingers to indicate the number of bullets inside. They needed to make sure to use them wisely until they got to their bags upstairs.

Right as they were about to run straight for their room, a string of loud bangs trembled from inside the building. Both froze on the spot because it sounded like a struggle. They cut their eyes at each other. They homed in their sharp hearing to focus in on where the sounds were coming from.

The source was around the corner. They slyly moved towards the source of the ruckus down a long, dark hall.

As they crouched, they noticed there were traces of blood caked in the floorboards. It was evidence of a brawl and Izuku felt a huge weight of guilt come down on him. He hoped with everything he had that no one was harmed. He didn't know if he could live with more added guilt that someone else died at the hands of his family while in pursuit of them.

When they came to the epicenter of the voices, it was directly behind the doors of the cafeteria. Soft sobs could be heard on the other side. Izuku peered around carefully, keeping himself masked in the shadows. He was able to peer through the sliver of a crack between the doors. He clenched his jaw.

He saw five lower ranked vipers standing there.

Their faces were vaguely familiar. He recognized some of them as siblings who always admired the Viper Seven. They were poised with their guns directly at all the bathhouse employees. Each person was on their knees with their hands up while fear rolled off their bodies.

Everyone seemed terrified except Nemuri. She was wearing a hardened, war-stricken expression. Murder was dancing in her eyes and there were bruises all along her face. She was fairly beaten up from what seemed like a three on one battle.

"Someone should go check in on Blood Viper and Double Headed Viper," one of the viper spoke. "I haven't heard any screaming in a while. They might've completed the assignment."

“I’ll go,” another viper replied. “Hey, maybe after we bring back Viridian’s spoiled ass, we can leverage it into Tomura giving us a promotion. He’s been in the worst goddamn mood without him. He’ll probably agree to whatever once he gets his Little back.”

Sick, humor filled laughs echoed out.

Izuku leaned back quickly when one of his siblings began to walk towards the door.

He signaled with his hand for Katsuki to get ready.

His husband stationed himself strategically next to the door.

When the lower ranked viper came out, Katsuki immediately snatched them. He muffled the man’s yell with his large hand and snapped his neck in a sharp, quick movement. The sound of the vertebrae breaking was barely audible as the body went entirely limp in his arms. Quietly, Katsuki lowered the dead man down on the ground.

He held up his gun and strategically pointed the barrel through the crack in the door.

He put his finger on the trigger.

Three concise shots were fired.

Three heavy thuds were heard from the inside.

A sudden yell of confusion from the last Viper standing cued them to move quickly. They rushed inside of the cafeteria, ready with their weapons raised.

The last Viper immediately pointed his gun at them. But before the Viper could pull the trigger, Nemuri jumped to her feet. She moved into action, and revealed a hidden knife that was tucked underneath her dress. She slit the viper’s throat without hesitation the moment he took eyes off her. The Viper’s eyes bulged. He grappled at his throat that was now raining crimson as he dropped to his knees.

He choked and gasped until he finally keeled over.

With pure satisfaction, Nemuri’s cold eyes watched the body tumble down to the ground, dead.

A sigh of relief rang out. Takeyama held her hand over her heart and Ryoku shakily scrubbed her hands down her face. Sekijiro was clutching his arm that was bleeding.

Nemuri quickly jogged towards the window and peered out of it and then shut the blinds. She repeated this action several times over until all the curtains were drawn. Nemuri turned her hardened gaze on both Izuku and Katsuki.

“Are you two alright?” Nemuri asked sternly.

“Okay as we can be,” Katsuki replied.

Nemuri kicked the dead body on the ground. She watched the Viper on the ground twitch until they no longer did, and their eyes rolled back. She scoffed and scowled.

“Who was that?” Nemuri questioned.

“It was the Vipers,” Izuku answered quietly. A shadow stretched across his face. “I’m so sorry. They came here for us.”

“Unfortunately,” Katsuki whispered. “We might need to get a move on before more assassins come. But did you want us to stay behind for added protection? We could help.”

“No need,” Nemuri muttered, fully on high alert. “They caught us off guard because of the fireworks, but that won’t happen again. If those really are the Vipers, you two need to get a move on like you said. I think I saw a couple of untagged cars in town as well. They were driving slowly, and that’s when I decided to turn around and make sure you both were alright.”

“Yeah, and then we were ambushed,” Ryoku added. “But next time there won’t be an easy ensnarement.”

“I’m so sorry for bringing this here,” Izuku said with his head down. “I didn’t think they would find us so quickly.”

“You have nothing to be sorry for,” Nemuri quickly corrected. She walked up to him and put a kind hand on his shoulder. She smiled the best she could and shook her head. “But you should never underestimate the resources the Yakuza has. Nor should you doubt the number of eyes they have crawling all over the damn place.”

Katsuki wearily glanced off to the side. He then said, “We should really get going before more come.”

“I agree,” Izuku whispered. “Thank you all for your hospitality. I’m r-really sorry for the mess we’ve left behind.”

“We’ll be able to handle ourselves, don’t worry at all,” Takeyama reassured.

Next, Sekijiro walked up to them hastily. He carefully peered at the endless cuts, scrapes, and wounds on their bodies. At this point, both of their purple uniforms were polka dotted with blood. The fabric had been cut up to the point the thin cloth was nearly shredded off their bodies.

“Let me patch you both up before you go,” Sekijiro suggested urgently. “Some of these look really nasty. Especially that shoulder wound on you, Izuku. You won’t be able to function properly once the adrenaline wears off.”

Izuku peered down and he was greeted with overwhelming blood sliding down his arm. Katsuki was wearily looking at that wound as well as Nemuri. Izuku winced. Himiko had done a damn good job at injuring him where it counted.

“Yeah, You’re right. Bandages would be good,” Izuku agreed shakily. “Th-Thank you.”

“And a fuck ton of pain killers too,” Katsuki added in.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Cleanup was more efficient than Izuku thought it was going to be.

There had been a secret room neither Izuku nor Katsuki knew about that was in a clandestine back room. It was full of cleaning supplies, and more surprisingly, large baths for acid. As all the employees took a post, it didn’t seem like the first time this group had disposed of bodies —and it certainly didn’t feel like it would be the last either.

Izuku and Katsuki sat in chairs as Sekijiro tended to them in the secret room. As his wounds were stitched up, Izuku watched as Ryoku lowered all the Vipers into an acid bath she prepared.

When their flesh hit the liquid, it hissed like a snake.

Izuku stared on without blinking.

“We need to make a plan to keep out of their reach until we can make it to Nana,” Katsuki whispered beside him as Sekijiro cleaned his cut with an alcohol swab. “We’re not going to be able to slow down now.”

“Is there any place you can think of for us to hide?” Izuku asked wearily.

“No,” Katsuki said gravely. “Nemuri? Is there any place you know we could go?”

“I’m sorry, there’s not,” Nemuri reluctantly replied.

Katsuki exhale roughly. He said, “I guess we’re going to have to keep cutting these bastards down in the meantime until I get a call back from my ex-supervisor. We’re officially on the run.”

A moment of silence stretched between everyone as the acid bath sizzled.

Izuku focused in on Jin and Himiko’s bodies. They sank down deeper and deeper into the dark liquid like they were being consumed in quicksand. When the last strand of blond hair disappeared beneath the surface, all that was staring back at them were the ripples in the acid.

In that small riptide, Izuku saw a lifetime of memories involving Himiko and Jin. None of them were particularly pleasant, but that didn’t stop Izuku from feeling a bit of solemness.

This officially only left him and Tomura as the lone survivors of the Viper Seven.

“What are you thinking about?” Katsuki asked.

“Nothing important,” Izuku replied quietly without taking his eyes off the bath.

Katsuki held his hand lightly. “You can tell me, no judgment.”

Izuku turned hesitantly to his husband. They leveled gazes and the words stumbled off his tongue.

“I’ve killed everyone from my unit except Tomura,” Izuku confessed. He blinked rapidly, and he sucked in a deep breath. “And we all were raised together. Is it bad that I don’t feel guilty for any of their deaths except for Hiryu’s?”

“No.” Katsuki clenched his jaw. “Fuck them.”

“I think the worst part is, I never wanted to see any of them die, despite knowing they wouldn’t have cared if I did,” Izuku murmured. “I thought maybe there was a chance Himiko wouldn’t care about me leaving because she hated me so much. But I was fooling myself. Everyone I grew up with were always real vipers.”

“You only did what you had to do in order to survive,” Katsuki tried to reassure him. He squeezed his hand. “If it’s between you or those fuckers, you should always choose yourself.”

Izuku squeezed his hand back.

He sucked in his lips and his eyes skirted back to the acid bath. In his ear the fizzling sounds multiplied louder and louder until he swore, he heard Jin and Himiko’s haunting laughs mix together.

ɯɯɯ

Once they were all patched up, all the employees in the bathhouse armed themselves.

Each took a weapon from Nemuri’s collection while Izuku and Katsuki changed out of their uniforms. There was no time to wipe away the blood. They jumped into their winter clothes and pulled on their jackets. Nemuri slung two bullet proof vests towards them, and Katsuki locked and loaded several of his guns into his holster.

When it was the dead of night, it was officially time for them to embark.

Both stood in the doorway, and the brisk winter winds blew through their skin.

How fast the night had changed. And this was likely only the beginning of their troubles now that they had been discovered. The faint smell of iron chipped into the air and Izuku felt uncertainty stare back at him from the other side of the night.

He turned to Nemuri. She was already looking at him, with tears in her eyes.

Izuku smiled weakly. He approached her and gave her a tight, warm hug. She returned it back to him tenfold, and the affection between them compressed. He felt a sting in his heart and knew he would miss her. Even though he had only known her a short time, he finally felt like he understood kindness a bit more because of her. Izuku nearly didn’t want to let go.

He squeezed his eyes shut tightly as she cradled his head.

“Thank you so much for everything,” Izuku whispered gently.

“I would do it again in a heartbeat,” Nemuri whispered back. She away from the embrace and nodded to him and Katsuki. “Make sure you both live a full life.”

“We’ll try our best,” Katsuki said. “Thank you for everything you’ve done for us. Please stay safe the best you can.”

All the employees said their goodbyes and after that it was time to go.

They both hurried towards Katsuki’s motorcycle and packed up. Izuku and Katsuki put on the bullet proof vests under their jackets. It was heavy but Izuku was more than thankful for it right now. Who knew who was waiting on the inside of the night for them. Katsuki climbed on his motorcycle, and Izuku followed suit with his pulse pounding in his ear.

When he was fully seated, Izuku positioned the bulletproof duffle bag Nana had given him so that it covered his back. They put on their helmets and Katsuki revved the engine. They peered around and found no one else lurking in the shadows.

When Izuku locked his arms around Katsuki’s waist, he couldn’t help but look back. He felt compelled as if there was a string attached to his head that pulled him.

He saw Nemuri standing there with a heavy heart and fear loudly screaming in her eyes.

Katsuki didn’t look back as he took off into the foggy night.

ᔓᔓᔓ

They were unsure where they were heading.

All they knew is that they needed to get far away and fast. Izuku kept a look out for any suspicious movements as Katsuki sped off down the empty highways. The streetlights felt like fleeting stars passing them at light speed. The only things Izuku could see was the road, those passing lights, and the blank sky above.

After about two hours of straight driving, the bone chilling winter was beginning to sting. He tucked his hands underneath Katsuki’s jacket and huddled in closer. He rested his pounding head against Katsuki’s back as they slowly came to halt at a red light.

Izuku glanced around, and the dark silence prickled his skin. They were the only vehicle around.

Katsuki turned his head slightly and audibly sighed.

“I’m low on gas,” Katsuki announced begrudgingly. “We have to stop at a station soon.”

“Here I was, hoping we had unlimited fuel,” Izuku replied tiredly. He hugged Katsuki closer. “Let’s try our best to make it quick.”

They found a gas station on the edge of the next city in their path.

It stood out like an oasis of light in the vast darkness. The neon blue and red lights offered no real comfort. But what did was the small storefront that was attached. There was yellow warmth radiating from the inside and Izuku could see the shining bald head of a man as they drew closer.

Katsuki parked the motorcycle at the nearest pump and kicked up the stand.

Izuku hopped off first and began stretching his arms. Katsuki fluidly swung his legs around and cracked his back. Neither of them made a move to take their helmets off. It was a silent understanding that they were being careful to avoid being identified.

As Katsuki pumped gas, Izuku kept a sharp lookout.

He was keen on any sounds or movements. But no matter how hard he searched, all he found was emptiness. It was engulfing them like they were on a tiny island, stranded in the middle of a sea of shadows. Truthfully, he didn't know whether to be worried or thankful that there wasn't anyone nearby.

When the click of the pump signaled their tank was full, Katsuki took out the nozzle and hung it up on the station. He turned to Izuku and jutted his head towards the store.

"Let's go inside and pay in cash," Katsuki said.

Izuku nodded, and they began to walk into the store together.

A melodic bell echoed when they entered through the door. The clerk that was inside perked up. He was an elderly man with a full face and a slightly red nose. He was huddled over the counter and offered a warm smile that translated through his honey brown eyes.

"Welcome, welcome!" The elderly man greeted cheerfully. "I hope you two are having a great night!"

Izuku and Katsuki made disgruntled, but agreeable sounds.

As Katsuki began paying for gas, Izuku's eyes wandered the small shop. He counted the colorful candy bars and pondered how many visitors this man received through the night.

When the register chimed, signaling their transaction was complete, Izuku's eyes wandered up towards the foggy mirror above him. Then he halted entirely. In the fisheye he saw the distorted image of headlights approaching in the distance. Suddenly the sound of multiple car engines revved through the walls.

All three men sharply turned towards the glass door.

Driving up were four cars.

All the hairs on Izuku's arm stood up. With a bated breath, he waited for them to pass. Katsuki clenched his jaw when they came closer, and he cursed out loud when they began to slow down.

They all pulled up, surrounding Katsuki's motorcycle.

Both Izuku and Katsuki immediately went on high alert.

Underneath the iridescent lights of the gas station, the details of the cars were revealed. They were sleek, deep black and all perfectly shined. The windows on all the vehicles were tinted, the rims were gold and there was not a license plate in sight.

Izuku immediately recognized the odd uniformity of the cars. But worse, he saw the flower-like symbol of the Shie Hassasikai that was embedded in gold on one of the cars.

"Oh my, what a busy night I'm having today," the clerk said curiously. He took his glasses out of his shirt pocket and put them on his face. "How peculiar. I don't usually have this many customers this time of night."

He limped around the counter and tried to get a better look. But quickly Izuku shot a hand out and stopped him.

The clerk looked over his shoulder and asked innocently, "What's the matter, young man?"

"*Don't*," Izuku whispered harshly. He shook his head as his eyes darted between the clerk and the four cars outside. "Don't let them in."

At that, the clerk's posture straightened out. The little bit of color that was in his cheeks vanished and he turned his eyes to the posse of cars parked outside. He squinted and swiftly a ghostly expression washed across his face.

He saw the Yakuza symbol crystal clear.

Katsuki began reaching for his gun. "Lock the front door."

The clerk did precisely that with extra haste.

"Do you have a back door we could exit out of?" Izuku asked quickly as he began scoping out the small store. He pulled down the blinds and pulled out his gun too.

"Ye-Yes, towards the back," the clerk replied. He dryly swallowed when suddenly Katsuki cocked his weapon. "Wh-What's going on? Why do you all have guns?!"

"Go hide in the back closet, and don't come out for anything," Katsuki answered selectively. He pointed to the utility room and the old man flinched unwillingly. "Be as quiet as you can be if you want to keep your life."

The doors on the cars opened and out poured men in all black.

"Shit," Izuku hissed.

The clerk quickly ran towards the closet door and locked himself in. He didn't spare a single look back while Izuku and Katsuki ran towards the back door. They immediately flung it open, and quietly pressed themselves against the back side of the building.

Loud banging pounded on the door.

“Open up!” A gruff voice of a man yelled. “You have until the count of three! Or we will not spare you!”

Izuku and Katsuki exchanged a single glance. They began carefully tiptoeing towards the corner of the store.

“One!”

They reached the corner, and Izuku peered around.

“Two!”

He saw the motorcycle awaiting them on the other side.

“*Three*!”

The sound of glass shattering to the ground nearly made Izuku flinch.

His senses reactivated to their highest level once more. Everything began to move in slow motion. He could hear the footsteps of the yakuza rush into the store. Their boots crunched the glass under their feet as they cocked their weapons. Violent clamoring became the ticking countdown to get the hell out of here.

They made a run for it.

They sprinted straight across the gas station, going full speed.

Someone shouted, exposing them. “They’re outside! Stop them before they get away!”

A parade of bodies chasing after them ensued. Izuku and Katsuki jumped the cars blocking the bike, sliding across the hoods. Bullets whizzed right past Izuku to try to kill Katsuki. When one bounced off Katsuki’s helmet, Izuku’s heart stopped. Then fury burned through his veins.

As Katsuki turned on the motorcycle, Izuku’s killer instinct activated fully. His pupils narrowed down as he locked on to the Yakuza men flooding out of the store.

He shot two down right through the heart where they stood.

“C’mon!” Katsuki shouted.

Izuku quickly spun on his feet. He barely made it on the back of the motorcycle before Katsuki sped off. They skirted forward, narrowly maneuvering between the cars blocking their way.

Deadly bullets whizzed past Izuku’s head, aiming for Katsuki—and Katsuki only.

Their whole world jerked forward at high speed. They took off into the night at the fastest velocity Izuku had ever seen Katsuki drive. He clung on tightly, and the winds began to cut straight through them. It didn't take long for the smell of burning rubber to fill the air. Several sets of blinding headlights began to chase right behind them. The lights grew larger and larger, and Izuku felt like prey.

Katsuki cursed out loud when a bullet nearly nicked him. He kicked up the speed and began to zig zag.

More bullets tried to hit Katsuki and Izuku looked behind them. The blinding headlights mixed in with their unsteady motions made it extremely difficult to focus. But Izuku homed in. He was able to decipher that all four cars were coming right after them at full speed. Each vehicle had a person with a rifle standing up through the sunroof trying to shoot them down.

Izuku adjusted himself. He held on securely to Katsuki's middle with one arm. He twisted his body and took aim with his gun. He tried to take down the men in the sunroofs—but missed when the cars jerked out of the way.

He took several more fruitless shots. He clenched his teeth as sweat began to profusely pour down his forehead. This was going to be too difficult like this. His aim was too rocky between Katsuki's maneuvering and the yakuza's dodging.

But Izuku knew that unless they killed these henchmen, they were not going to make it out of here alive.

"Do you think you can take them out?!" Katsuki yelled as he shifted them out of the way of another bullet.

"I can do it, but I need you to get me closer!" Izuku shouted back. "Or put me on an angle!"

Katsuki nodded and leaned forward.

They hit a curve in the road, and it twisted them around. For a split second, it gave Izuku the right point of view and he did not waste it. He fired off three bullets into the closest car: one shattered the window, one hit the driver, and the last one hit the man hanging out the sunroof.

The car began to spin out.

Loud, abrupt skidding alarmed everyone as the car tumbled at high-speed. It hit a bump in the road and flipped on its head. Glass sprayed everywhere like rain. Izuku shielded his face, and Katsuki didn't take his foot off the gas. When Izuku looked again, he saw flames arising from the belly-up car. The other three cars jerked around the mayhem and continued to chase them in hot pursuit.

The road straightened out again, and Izuku's head rattled around. He held his grip on Katsuki firmly as he aimed with the other hand. He tried his best to take out the other three cars but was faced with the same problem. Right when Izuku wished he could get closer, their pursuers began to kick it up a notch.

The sound of shifting gears clanked. Rubber burned hotter against the pavement and the cars began to gain on them at an unnerving speed. Izuku's eyes widened when suddenly they were beginning to become boxed in. Two cars pulled up on the side, and another pressed right on their bumper.

"I should have fucking set that goddamn opera house on fire and killed all these bastards," Katsuki hissed.

The two cars next to them began to close in.

They crept uncomfortably close until the smell of exhaust choked Izuku. Hands began grappling at him, trying to take hold of his arm. Izuku quickly jerked out of the way. Instead of grabbing him, the men ate the barrel of his gun. He shot two men at point blank range in the arm and then again in the head. He pulled the trigger again to kill the driver—but the gun clicked empty.

Izuku reloaded quickly, using only one hand. He put the barrel of the gun in his mouth and snatched the extra rounds out of his jacket pocket. He reloaded the gun rapidly. He whipped his pistol back in his hand and aimed straight for the driver.

Then suddenly a hand grappled him from the opposite side. Izuku yelped as he was violently pulled towards the other car.

Everything began to tip sideways as Katsuki's balance was knocked off. The motorcycle became uneasily wobbly, and both of their hearts began pounding. Hands began trying to pull Izuku through the car window and Izuku struggled against them.

Katsuki quickly recovered and Izuku snatched his limb back. The man tried to grab him again, but Katsuki moved sharply. He kept one hand on the bike's handle and pulled out his gun. Within the blink of an eye, Katsuki shot the man in the head at point blank range.

Izuku twisted and aimed his gun to the driver's head. He successfully landed a shot. Katsuki switched hands and did the same thing for the other car. Both vehicles on either side of them came to devastating, hard stops. Each car twirled out of control and rolled off the road. They crashed off into the grass and left chaos in their wake.

There was only one car left now.

The car that was tailing their bumper tried to rear end them off the road. The hit was hard enough to jerk the bike out of control. Izuku held on for dear life as he was rocked forward. Katsuki cursed and tried to jerk to the side, but the car did the same thing as him.

It kept on their tail like glue and began to ram them over and over.

Izuku tried again to shoot from an awkward angle with one hand. But right as he was about to pull the trigger, the car rammed them again—but this time harder than before. Izuku yelled as the grip he had on Katsuki was lost.

He toppled backwards unexpectedly, but Katsuki's hand shot out behind him in the nick of time. His husband grabbed him by his jacket and held him with pure might. Katsuki pulled Izuku forward and Izuku clung to him right away again using both arms.

"Hold on tight," Katsuki warned.

That was all Izuku got before Katsuki chaotically steered the motorcycle. He spun the bike around so fast that Izuku had to close his eyes. His head twisted like he was on an extreme rollercoaster. He hugged Katsuki's midsection with all he had as they spun around and around.

When the wind was cutting into him in the opposite direction, Izuku finally opened his eyes. They were racing back in the direction they came. The car behind them was making a frenzied U-Turn, trying to keep close.

"I'm going to turn around again," Katsuki yelled over the roaring winds. "Take them out through the window when we cut past them."

"Got it," Izuku responded.

He held on tight as Katsuki jerked the bike around. They only gained speed as Katsuki began barreling towards the car. They were heading towards a collision. It was nearly a game of chicken, and the car was not moving out of the way.

Izuku readied himself and held up his gun. He closed one eye to tighten his aim.

When they closed the distance, Katsuki skirted slightly to the right by an inch. They passed each other and both Izuku and the passenger in the car held up their guns. The adrenaline in his blood made everything slow down.

He saw the two people in the car. He saw the viciousness in their eyes. He saw the passenger take aim with a tranquilizer bullet. For anyone else, this would be the end—but Izuku's killer instinct was sharpened by Tomura himself.

Izuku's quick trigger finger worked its deathly magic.

His bullet sliced through the air at precisely the right time. It cut through the head of the passenger clean, and then barreled into the driver's temple. Both men fell forward, dead instantly. Two for the price of one. The car spun out just like the others did.

It came to a dramatic halt, leaving behind road marks that had steam rising to the sky.

Katsuki came to a steady, but fast stop.

He turned the motorcycle to the side, and both looked at the car. They waited for any signs of life. But none came. They glanced behind them, awaiting more potential enemies, but no one was in sight. The night echoed only their heavy breathing.

They were officially alone again—barely escaping the narrow grasp of death once more.

Izuku lowered his gun.

He scanned his eyes across the scene. They were close to where the other two cars had crashed off the road. Small fires had caught under the hoods of those vehicles. Scattered like confetti, debris was everywhere. Car parts, stray bullets, and blood were stacked up and down the vacant road.

Without dropping their guard, Izuku and Katsuki climbed off the bike.

Izuku kept his hand on his gun and so did Katsuki. They quietly surveyed the madness together. Katsuki slowly took off his helmet and his face was drenched in sweat. His bangs were plastered to his forehead and the weariest expression Izuku had ever seen him with was taped across his face.

“What the absolute fuck,” Katsuki harshly whispered.

Izuku took off his helmet as well. Cold, fresh air filled his lungs, and he pushed back his damp hair out of his face. His eyes stretched wide as he stared at the tiny fires up and down the road.

“How could they find us?” Izuku asked, utterly baffled. “This doesn’t make sense—we’re in the middle of nowhere. There was no one tailing us from when we left the bathhouse. I’m *sure* of it.”

There was no answer from his husband.

Katsuki seemed equally as puzzled. His gaze frantically darted all over as he investigated the chaotic scene. He stalked up to one of the flipped cars and then stood over a lukewarm body that had been launched from the window.

Then suddenly, Katsuki’s posture snapped upright like a light bulb went off.

He whipped his head around so fast Izuku worried if he hurt himself.

Katsuki stared directly at his bright, red motorcycle.

“It’s my *bike*,” he hissed bitterly.

In a whirl of frustration, Katsuki flung his head back and gestured to the vehicle in disbelief. Izuku’s eyes widened, and it clicked in place. Izuku stared wide eyed in horror at what had possibly given them away.

“*Fuck*!” Katsuki let out a loud, disgruntled groan and gripped his hair. “Fuck. Fuck. *Fuck*. And they could be tracking my phone if they have as many resources as you say they do. I have anti-tracking software on all my devices, but maybe someone got past my firewall.”

Izuku rubbed his forehead to ease the growing headache.

But quickly, the answer felt so painfully obvious. *Of course*.

The Vipers probably had been tracing them through CCTV footage this whole time. Izuku ignorantly assumed that without Aoyama, that their technological reach would be hindered. But of course, even though Aoyama was the best, it doesn't mean he was the only one who could excel. Especially when the right pressure was applied.

Izuku wondered if Tomura knew where he was this whole time. What if his Big Brother was simply waiting until ready to come collect him?

A chill ran down his bones at that thought.

“Damn it all,” Katsuki cursed angrily. He slammed the bike helmet on to the ground in pure anger and groaned. “We’re going to have to go dark completely with these fucking blood hounds. No bike. No phone. No contact with anyone. We can’t even so much as *breathe* in the wrong city otherwise they’ll send another goddamn squad.”

Izuku closed his eyes and tried to breathe. He couldn’t help but blurt out the obvious question that their whole survival hinged on.

“What about the call from your supervisor?” Izuku asked. “We can’t get rid of your phone just yet.”

Katsuki dropped his head slightly and the hope in his eyes was fading.

“We’ll have to play it risky until it gets too hazardous,” Katsuki muttered reluctantly. He fixed his gaze on Izuku very seriously. “How are you on ammo?”

“I have a fair number of rounds left,” Izuku muttered. He inhaled deeply and let out a rickety breath. “But not enough for an entire month and a half worth of shoot outs like this. I could only probably last another five ambushes before I’m forced to only use a blade.”

“Same.”

Katsuki crossed his arms and grew silent. He delved into deep thought as he stared down at the corpse laying at his feet. He kicked the body over, studying the man’s bloodied, road burned face.

“Once we ditch the motorcycle, we’ll be able to buy some time—but not a lot,” Katsuki muttered unhappily. “In the meantime, we’ll keep the phone—but only until my shitty ass supervisor calls me back. After that, we’ll destroy it immediately. So, let’s hope he calls before someone tries to take my head off again.”

With bitterness, the two of them left their helmets on the side of the road.

They didn’t look back as they walked up to the one car that was still in decent condition.

They both began to search everywhere in the vehicle for any cell phones, trackers, or laptops. They scanned thoroughly, patting their hands everywhere. Sweat beaded on Izuku’s forehead as they did this because he knew they couldn’t screw this up.

Every single device they found they smashed it to bits.

Upon completing that task, the two of them wordlessly transferred all their bags into the car.

“We should drive to the next city over and steal another vehicle,” Katsuki said. “We’ll be okay in this, but only for a few hours. But it’ll be good enough to confuse them.”

They opened the doors to drag the dead bodies out. Katsuki unceremoniously tossed the dead Yakuza man on the pavement. Izuku reached for the second body inside, but paused momentarily when he recognized who it was.

He leaned in. Gradually, the familiar face began to fill him with dread.

“What’s wrong?” Katsuki asked when he saw his sudden hesitance.

“This person is a Viper,” Izuku said. His heart dropped and Katsuki locked his eyes on the dead corpse in the driver’s seat. “If this Viper is with a Yakuza, then…then that means they’ve teamed up.”

“Oh, *perfect*,” Katsuki grumbled sarcastically. “Those bastards are officially working together to bring us in.”

Izuku didn’t respond because working together could mean a lot of things. It could mean Chisaki hired the leftover Vipers to come and find them. It could mean maybe there was a momentary collaboration to get things done quicker.

Or meant one other thing—the thing that Izuku feared the most.

Izuku laid the vaguely familiar Viper down on the ground. He looked at his fallen sibling and then his eyes trailed down to his pockets. He patted the corpse down and found the silver cellular device all Viper’s carried.

Izuku entered their universal pin code and searched through the emails.

He scrolled back by date, scanning all the subject lines. Many of them were labeled urgent and sent by either Tomura, One, Ms. Nagant or Mr. Compress. Every single email was about a shortage of Vipers and the state of assignments. Until he found an email from three days ago.

> **From:** Mamushi Tomura
>
> **To:** Tokyo Vipers
>
> **CC:** One
>
> **Subject line:** URGENT: Shie Hassaikai Merger under way and Viridian Viper Situation
>
> All,
>
> Thank you for your cooperation over the last two weeks. I know it has been a trying time given the circumstances. The number of Vipers lost to Viridian Viper’s defective actions has undoubtedly affected us all. Many missions have been canceled and as a

result, some of our clients have pulled their support to seek business elsewhere until we get everything under control.

Because of this, we are down in fiscal numbers. However, after discussing the situation with One, together we have arrived at a solution that would be able to mend this fiasco.

As of now, it is in our best interest to begin pursuing a merger with our biggest clientele, the Shie Hassaikai.

I know this comes as a surprise for many of you. But after much discussion with One, we feel as if it is the best course of action. Once the merger is complete, this will mean our family will function as a faction of the Yakuza rather than assassins for hire. This union will allow us to recover the number of forces we have lost from the fire and the murders. Additionally, we will be able to recover financially from having clients pull away. We will also be able to gain access to unlimited Yakuza resources that would help us begin preparing a new cohort.

Mr. Chisaki, One, and I met and hashed out a proper business deal. We wanted to make sure this moves forward with all parties' best interest in mind. There have been many conditions set on both sides. However, two large conditions were set by Mr. Chisaki, and they are non-negotiable:

1. The Viridian Viper must be delivered to him.
2. Bakugou Katsuki must be killed for murdering his family members.

As of now, both are a priority. The merger cannot move forward until these tasks are completed. Going onward I will be selectively dispatching you all to complete these checklist items.

I will be answering all suitable questions at the next all hands meeting, which will be scheduled for tomorrow at 18:00 in the Grand Hall.

Signed,

Mamushi Tomura, The Horned Viper.

Izuku's world warped as he stared at the e-mail. He breathed out unevenly and glanced at Katsuki, who was reading along with him over his shoulder. The tension in the air became palatable with disdain. Katsuki's anger was simmering on low heat, ready to explode.

"C'mon." Katsuki's nostrils flared and he looked Izuku dead in his eye. "Let's get the fuck out of here."

ᔓᔓᔓ

The entire drive, Katsuki held his hand.

There was a wordless connection between the two of them as they began to melt into their new reality. Izuku tried his best not to spiral. But it was difficult. He found himself thinking

about that email detailing the merger, especially the part about Katsuki.

When they finally made it to the next town over, immediately Katsuki began scouting for a discreet car to hijack.

“Let’s try to make sure we don’t take some family’s minivan or something,” Katsuki mumbled as he drove through the city slowly. “I’d feel sort of bad if we took something like that.”

The comment made Izuku give a short, humorless laugh.

“Wow,” he said in a slightly amused tone. He turned to his husband and cocked his head. “Never thought you would be so thoughtful while trying to steal a car. You really are the nicer one between the two of us, I think.”

Katsuki scoffed. “I’m not that damn nice.”

Izuku held back a small laugh. Katsuki then pulled into a residential area where rows and rows of cars were parked on the street. He drove by slowly and then finally stopped when they came upon what they were looking for.

“Ah, fuck yeah. That’s the one,” Katsuki whispered. He pointed with his finger. “That’ll be a perfect damn cover.”

The car Katsuki was pointing at was probably the most unremarkable vehicle Izuku had ever seen. It was slightly worn with a dent in the side and there was a layer of unwashed grime on it. A little yellow air freshener dangled from the rearview mirror. And it was a dark beige color, like it was trying not to stand out.

In short, it was exactly what they needed.

They pulled up beside the car and glanced around carefully. A single hand motion from Katsuki was all it took for them to jump out and immediately step into gear. Izuku kept checking over his shoulder, rightfully paranoid. And beside him Katsuki sat his back bag on the ground and opened it up.

To Izuku’s full surprise, Katsuki pulled out two fake license plates. Izuku blinked, taken back by the sheer level of preparation.

Katsuki caught his shocked face and smirked over his shoulder.

“What? Don’t seem so surprised,” Katsuki said a bit cockily. “I’ve learned a lot of tricks of the trade over the years. Stealing cars is only good if you can make them undetectable.”

Izuku let out a shy, nervous chuckle. “You are good. I feel stupid for ever doubting your abilities.”

His husband winked at him playfully then went back to being serious. Carefully, Katsuki undid the license plate from the car with a screwdriver. He focused on laser sharp and Izuku peered over his shoulder again.

With mindful precision, Katsuki replaced the real license plate with the one of his own.

He grunted as he finished and proceeded to do the same for the backside of the car. Quickly, Katsuki traced his hand on the under belly, making sure no trackers were attached. He nodded to Izuku then stood up. Using a tiny device he pulled from out of his pocket, he placed it methodically on the door handle. It blinked blue and suddenly the alarm on the car was disabled.

Katsuki began picking the lock.

Watching his lethal lover like this made the back of Izuku's head tingle. It could've been fatigue finally catching up with him, or maybe he was officially losing it. But it was oddly enticing to observe the range of Katsuki's impressive skills.

When the door sprung open, Izuku was deeply impressed.

His husband proceeded to get to work hot-wiring the vehicle. In the meantime, Izuku threw all their belongings in the backseat. There were some signs of life in the car like old receipts from Seven-Eleven and empty plastic cups of coffee.

The engine began revving loudly. Katsuki smirked at him from the driver's seat.

"Let's get going."

ᔓᔓᔓ

They drove further south with no stops. When they passed a sign that said, 'Welcome to Kitakyushu', it signaled to them that they were nearly all the way at the southernmost end of the country.

The radio played a song Izuku had never heard of as they reached the peak of night. Katsuki's eyes were beginning to droop, and it was obvious when they both felt the adrenaline come down. Izuku's shoulder was hurting, and Katsuki was stiffly moving his arms. When the ache in their backs became too much, they knew they needed to stop and rest.

Katsuki drove up to a secluded cliff top and parked the car off in the grass.

They were hidden slightly by the barren trees, and there wasn't much traffic coming in and out of the mountain road. They climbed into the backseat and used Katsuki's sleeping bag as a blanket to warm them up.

Katsuki sighed and his frosty breath spilled into the air. He pulled out his phone once more, leaned further into the makeshift blanket, and he began dialing the same contact once more.

This time, there was significant urgency in the air. Katsuki's usually steady hand was beginning to shake. The phone continued to ring and ring. The rhythm of the drawn-out tone was starting to sound like their funeral hymn.

When Izuku heard that dreaded flat beep his heart sank.

Katsuki couldn't even leave a voice mail because the inbox was officially full.

Katsuki pulled the phone away from his ear reluctantly.

"No dice," he said, sadly. "Yet again."

Izuku's bottom lip began to quiver. He tried to stop it because he didn't want to be weak—but it kept on.

He clenched his teeth and squeezed his eyes shut in frustration. All the day's events crammed into the forefront of his memory. He saw Jin and Himiko dissolving in acid. He saw Himiko's bloodied eye sockets staring back at him. He re-lived her vengeful words and felt the curse carry through the air.

Suddenly, a weight like granite appeared in his chest. It weighed him down until he let out a loud, saddened sob.

Katsuki sat up immediately, eyes wide. Izuku covered his mouth and lowered his head. He turned away as the cries spilled out and he didn't know what else to do.

"Hey, don't cry," Katsuki comforted right away. He reached over and pulled Izuku close to him. "Shit. Izuku, please don't cry."

"I'm sorry," Izuku said desolately. He turned his head into the crook of Katsuki's neck and hugged him. Katsuki hugged him back, threading his hands through his hair and shushing him. "I'm so sorry. I can't help it. I-I'm worried now. What if he doesn't call us back? What should we do? Do we find somewhere else to go? Nemuri was all Nana could give us. I-I feel so guilty dragging you into all of this. You were so happy at the estate and now you're back in this because of my *mess*."

"We'll get that call back, don't worry," Katsuki whispered. But even he didn't sound like he believed his words all the way. He held Izuku closer. "I promise you, we will."

"But it's been nearly two weeks," Izuku countered. "There's no way we can keep this up for six more weeks, Katsuki. We don't have the resources. And if the Vipers and Yakuza are working together that means there's more places we can't go and more eyes on us. A-And if they catch us, you'll—you'll—"

Another sob hit his lips.

Izuku dug his fingers into his husband as if he was already buried in his grave.

"I don't want you to die, Katsuki," Izuku wept. His voice cracked on the last syllable. "I don't think I-I could go on if you—"

"—Stop that," Katsuki snapped.

Izuku glanced up at his husband. Fierce, fire-like eyes were burning into him. Katsuki's face was distorted in anger, but not for him. He took Izuku's face in his hands and cradled his cheeks. Calloused thumbs wiped away the tears rolling down Izuku's cheeks.

“I’m not going to die,” Katsuki said firmly. “Especially not by the hands of some scummy ass yakuza. And I’m not going to let you come within a fucking inch of that *bastard*. I meant what I said in those shitty ass vows when I said I will kill anyone who gets between us. That includes yakuza, vipers and it especially includes your fucking brother.”

“You remember what you said during your drunk vows?” Izuku asked quietly.

Katsuki continued to wipe away his tears and nodded.

“Of course, the embarrassment that tape left me with is hard to forget,” Katsuki replied with half a laugh. “Sure, I was plastered, but those words were from the damn heart. And I don’t go back on promises very easily. Now, c’mon. Give me a smile. We did really fuckin’ great today—and we’ll keep doing great until we get to Nana.”

Izuku wanted to smile. He did. But it was impossible given the weight of what was resting on his shoulders.

“Y’know, I…have something that might really make you smile,” Katsuki said quietly.

“I don’t think anything could make me smile right now,” Izuku muttered.

Katsuki’s lips twitched into a smirk as if he knew a secret.

He grabbed for his backpack in the passenger seat and unzipped the small pocket on the front. Izuku could barely see what he was shifting for in this type of dark. But the tiniest bit of moonlight caught the glimmer of a green gem.

Katsuki held up his faux wedding ring from Okinawa.

Izuku’s heart thumped loudly, and his mouth went dry.

“Y-You kept it?” Izuku asked in disbelief. “After everything?”

“Mhm, I did,” Katsuki replied. He twirled it around, admiring it as if the rust from wear and tear wasn’t there. “I couldn’t find it in myself to toss it, even when I was blinded by anger. All I saw was you when I looked at this stupid little gem.”

Izuku smiled weakly.

“See, I told you it would make you smile,” Katsuki teased impudently.

He pinched Izuku’s cheek playfully and a bubble of laughter fell from Izuku’s lip. Izuku blushed, shyly smiled, and allowed Katsuki to plant a tiny kiss on his forehead. When Katsuki reeled back, Izuku’s eyes were slightly brighter.

“I actually still have mine as well, Kacchan,” Izuku confessed.

This time, it was Katsuki’s turn to be shocked. “You do?”

“Of course.”

Izuku reached forward and dipped his hand into his duffle bag. He pulled out the ruby ring.

Katsuki's face sparked to life. A short, hopeful laugh escaped past his lips as Izuku showed it to him.

Izuku was beaming through his tears now. They smiled radiantly at one another.

He had tucked away the small ring right before the masquerade. He'd been careful to hide it amongst his toiletries, thinking he would need it to get through the gut-wrenching task of entertaining Chisaki. Up until now, he had forgotten it. Or more so, he figured it was a lost cause given Katsuki's anger. He thought Katsuki likely had thrown his ring into the abyss and cursed his name.

But he was wrong—and he was so happy that he was.

Katsuki took the ruby ring from Izuku and slid it on his finger. Izuku did the same with the emerald ring for Katsuki and underneath the moonlight, the fake gems shined like they were worth millions of dollars. Izuku gazed into Katsuki's eyes and that magnetic pull that was between them deepened.

Their hands laced together in harmony and Katsuki leaned in to capture his lips.

Heat spilled down his body and Izuku melted underneath his husband's touch. He scooted in closer as Katsuki deepened the kiss. It felt beautiful. The way their bodies pressed flush together in the brittle cold was all the warmth Izuku thought he could ever need.

When they pulled back, Katsuki's eyes were set at half mast.

"We'll be okay," Katsuki murmured against his skin. They rested their foreheads together and cuddled further under the blanket. "When this is all over, we'll be living in our house in the countryside. And all this bullshit will be nothing but a bad memory."

They intertwined their hands, and the green and red gems gleamed as brightly as their love.

ɯɯɯ

A melodic ringtone mixed in with the singing of birds. Izuku's ears were graced with this appeasing harmony, and it softly roused him from his sleep. He gently yawned and Katsuki's body shifted as well. They both blinked their eyes open at the sound of the ringtone.

When the second loop of the song occurred, it instantaneously shot Katsuki out of his drowsiness. He sprang up and hastily grappled for his black phone. He flipped it open, and the loudest, longest exhale of relief expelled from him.

"You *bastard*," Katsuki said. "It's about time you called me back, old man."

Izuku heard the agitated voice of a man on the other end of the line say, "What the *hell* have you gotten yourself into, Bakugou?"

Chapter End Notes

Please let me know what you think below!! Thanks so much for sticking with this journey <3 I appreciate each and everyone one of you ^^

Chapter 34: Unison

Chapter Summary

> Unison: (Instrumentation Instructions) Players strike a chord together at the same time.

Chapter Notes

> Helloooo! So sorry about the disappearance :) I was in Asia traveling and then had some life events happen directly after. All good things so no worries but I'm back and able to sit down and finally wrap up the last leg of this story!! I'm so excited for it and I hope you are too!!!
>
> Beta'd by the LOML, Luna ❤️
>
> **Warnings: Cheesiness and Violence**

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 34 — Unison

.

.

.

Izuku's eyes widened. This was Katsuki's supervisor, wasn't it?

"Did you get my voicemails?" Katsuki asked quickly.

Within a split second a maelstrom of words were thrown his way.

"Get them?" The man snapped. The octave raised so sharply that Katsuki flinched. "Did I *get* them?" Katsuki pulled the phone away from his ear and groaned. "Bakugou, I was *bombarded* with them—while I was on *vacation*! I just finished listening to every single one. What the fuck is *wrong* with you?! Do you have a death wish—"

The rampage went on until Katsuki scrambled to throw on his shoes. The car rocked with the hurried motions as the speaker blurted out a string of colorful insults that Izuku would never have thought to put together.

Katsuki huffed before throwing open the car door. The cold wind rolled in as Katsuki stepped outside.

“Sorry, give me one second to calm him down,” Katsuki grumbled and closed the door.

Izuku blinked once. Then twice.

He rubbed his half awake eyes, leaned in towards the door, and tried his best to listen intently. However, he was only able to grab bits and pieces of the conversation. If he could even call what he was hearing a conversation. A curse here. A groan there. It was mostly the man yelling and Katsuki reluctantly apologizing.

Soon the conversation evened out. Katsuki began speaking in a low whisper and the man calmed down enough to the point Izuku could no longer hear what was being said.

Through the fogged up window, Izuku observed his husband. Katsuki stationed one hand on his hip and dropped his head down between his shoulders. He was beginning to pace around, getting further and further away from the car until he was entirely out of ear shot.

Izuku twisted his cold hands to try to calm his erratic heart. But it didn’t help. His anxiety fought its way up his chest causing him to gnaw on his bottom lip until it bled.

When Katsuki finally turned around, the conversation had clearly ended.

His husband raced against the gusting winds to get in the car and slammed the door shut while shivering. Izuku shivered as well, sniffling as he rubbed his frost kissed nose to warm it.

“Well. I have good news and bad news,” Katsuki mumbled as he stroked his chin. He turned to Izuku with a concerned but hopeful expression. “Which one do you want first?”

“Er, what’s the good news?” Izuku replied anxiously.

“The good news is, he said he can take us in. He’s willing to help us stay low and give protection with a professional team. And he gave me the location of an extremely secluded safe house.”

Izuku’s eyes lit up and a blanket of relief fell over him as he smiled.

However, his happiness wasn’t mirrored. Sitting across from him, Katsuki was stuck in a pensive state. His eyes were quietly studying the small amount of blood smeared across Izuku’s bottom lip.

Izuku’s smile receded.

“What is the bad news?” Izuku asked seriously.

“The bad news is…he can’t help us get there,” Katsuki carefully explained. “Since we need to keep moving in order to not be sitting ducks, it gets complicated. If we weren’t being hunted, it would be easy. But we need to get rid of my phone to avoid being tracked. Our

only option is to go completely dark like we said. Which means I can't contact him anymore. He gave me the location—we have to make it there and once we do we're golden."

"…And where do we need to go exactly?"

This is where Katsuki tensed up.

"It's Mount Rausu."

Izuku balked. "Huh?"

"I know—"

"—That's entirely the opposite direction of where we are. What—" Izuku leaned back, eyes stretched wide. "Why so far?"

Katsuki didn't reply back right away. There was a small, tense moment as Katsuki broke eye contact.

"Things…changed," is all Katsuki gave.

"R-Right." Izuku glanced off to the side, cursing internally. "Of course."

Silence took a seat between them as they absorbed the reality of the long road ahead. Izuku tried his hardest to focus on the good news mostly.

Was it far? Sure. But this was a clear path to safety and getting to Nana within the next six weeks—exactly what they so desperately need. Izuku mentally attempted to hash out the quickest route possible. But even with a car and nonstop driving, that left them with at least a thirty three hour drive. And that wasn't even accounting for other variables that could cause trouble along the way.

A sudden chill raked down his spine.

A threatening vision of Tomura ghosted across Izuku's vision. Even now he could feel his Big brother's sub zero gaze scanning the entire country to entrap him.

Just when Izuku felt his thoughts begin to spiral, Katsuki acted as if he could feel them too. He reached out and touched Izuku's hand and grounded him in the present.

"We can do this," Katsuki said firmly. "All we have to do is push forward for the next three—four days tops. Then it'll be alright."

A gentle sensation grazed across Izuku's forearms. It encased him like a warm, cozy blanket in the cold car. He pinned down the sensation as hope. It was fuzzy, scary, but it called to him that they had come this far and they could do this. When Katsuki cracked his signature crooked smile, Izuku felt his fear momentarily chased away.

"Ye-Yeah. You're right," Izuku agreed. He slowly nodded his head and Katsuki's smile grew larger and wider. "We can do this—together. We're always better together."

“Damn right we are.”

Now, they both were smiling.

Katsuki turned and reached for the map in the front seat. He shuffled around his backpack for a marker and circled exactly where they needed to go.

It was far. But it was doable.

Together, with the red marker, they mapped out the quickest route possible. They minimized stops and planned for rotating who was driving. When they finished their plan, the sun was fully seated up in the sky. It shone down on them brightly, signaling that it was time to get moving.

Katsuki took a deep breath and grabbed his phone with both of his hands.

He gritted his teeth and snapped it in two.



Izuku stared at the lopsided red circle on the map. He looked at it and tried his best to imagine what the safe house would be like.

Maybe it was a simple metal box. Faintly cold with stainless steel amenities and no entertainment. Or maybe it was an underground bunker of sorts—potentially constructed purely of concrete with various bits of furniture scattered around in a futile attempt to make it feel warm.

As Izuku ruminated, he tuned into the subtle tapping he was hearing next to him.

Katsuki was humming along to the radio while driving. His thumb was keeping beat to the bass as he pressed his foot on the gas. His husband’s intense eyes were focused on the long stretch of road. There weren’t many cars. They were passing through the southern countryside and all there was to see were rolling hills, dead grass and mountains.

Izuku gazed out of his window to take it all in. As he leaned against the headrest, he noted all the various patches of beige and the bright white snow that was sitting on the very top of the hills in the foreground.

As they drove by one particularly breathtaking mountain, an uncomfortable thought pushed itself forward.

This could truly be the very last time he was ever in Japan.

He had thought about it before at the water tower while gazing out at the sea. He had taken in the sights then, trying his best to savor them like a cold glass of water spilling down his throat. He wanted to appreciate every last drop, because if they were going to be free from the Vipers and Yakuza—leaving Japan was likely the one option they had.

“Enjoying the sights?” Katsuki asked in a light, playful tone.

Izuku turned to him and offered a smile. “I am. The mountain we just passed really caught my eye.”

“Yeah that thing was really something. Gotta love all the nature this far out.”

“It’s lovely…” Izuku’s voice trailed off as he stared at the passing mountain in the distance. It grew further and further away from them. “Y’know, I never really…appreciated all this before. But the landscape of Japan is really beautiful. I guess I took it for granted.”

“It’s easy to do that when you’ve grown up here,” Katsuki excused him. He gave a small shrug and took one hand off the wheel to pat Izuku’s leg. “Don’t feel too bad.”

Izuku didn’t respond back verbally. He simply glanced at the fading mountain, knowing there was a bittersweetness to the fact he never was going to see it again in his lifetime. The warm hand on his thigh didn’t leave and soon he felt Katsuki begin to trace tiny hearts into his pants.

“What are you thinking of?” Katsuki probed when silence rinsed over them.

Izuku shook his head. He straightened out his back in an attempt to hide his pensive state of mind.

“Nothing important,” he answered. “You know me. My brain is always on.”

But Katsuki saw right through him—like always. Izuku’s body might as well have been made of glass when it came to those scarlet eyes.

“C’mon, none of that,” Katsuki murmured. He ‘tsk’d under his breath and gave a playful, light pinch to Izuku’s thigh. “Cough it up.”

“Okay, Okay,” Izuku chuckled. He scratched behind his head and shrugged his shoulders tensely. “I guess I am…sad? I mean, I’m obviously sad about a lot of things. These last handful of weeks have been…insane. But it’s really hitting me that we’re going to be leaving Japan. It wasn’t until we were at the water tower that I realized I never got a genuine moment to appreciate what was around me. I’ve always been so…”

Izuku sucked at his teeth, trying to search for a word.

Sheltered? Isolated? *Deprived*?

“…Insulated,” he settled for.

Izuku waited for Katsuki’s response. He felt bad for constantly bringing up negative things like that, but he couldn’t help it. The lid was finally snapped off his mind and he could easily discuss his upbringing without feeling like his throat was going to clamp shut.

“I actually feel the same,” Katsuki replied.

Izuku softened at the kinship. “Really?”

“Yeah.” Katsuki shrugged. “Obviously your case is far more fucking extreme—but I never took a break to connect with nature and all that hippy dippy shit. There was never any time.” Katsuki frowned ever so slightly. “Too many bills to pay.”

Izuku pursed his lips to the side. He placed a gloved hand over Katsuki’s that was resting on his leg.

“Maybe in our next life we can have the time to really soak it all in,” Izuku reassured.

He imagined it: in the next cycle of their fates maybe they could slow down. They could have the opportunity to truly appreciate all that surrounds them and—

Suddenly, Katsuki sharply turned the car.

Izuku’s poetic thoughts were rattled about by quickened velocity. He yelped as his body ungracefully collided with the passenger seat door.

When the sound of tires burning on the concrete breached his ear, Izuku whirled his sights on his husband. He stared at him like he had gone crazy and judging by the mischievous grin plastered to Katsuki’s face, he just might’ve.

“Wh-What are you doing?!” Izuku yelled as he gripped the dashboard for dear life. Katsuki continued to turn the wheel sharply as if he was in some video game. He looked to Izuku, winked, and took the next exit.

“I refuse to leave shit up to reincarnation,” Katsuki blurted out. “We get one life.”

Before Izuku knew it, they were barreling towards a small pitstop that was tucked away off the side of the road. It consisted of a single gas station that had a handful of pumps and a FamilyMart. They came to a quick halt. They both jerked forward, saved by their seatbelt.

Izuku groaned and kept his head down. He rubbed his temples to restore some patience when he had the sudden urge to kick Katsuki’s ass.

“Sorry—I’ll be quick, I promise,” Katsuki said. He sprung out of the car in a blur.

Izuku didn’t have a chance to respond. He watched as Katsuki walked briskly through the automated glass doors.

A small, amused laugh slipped through Izuku’s lips. He tried to stifle it but the warmth of humor worked its way through his chest like tiny, lovely butterflies. He chuckled louder and louder until he was smiling so hard his cheeks hurt.

A day with Katsuki will never be dull, will it?

He found comfort in that. What a beautiful future they had together.

When Katsuki came back out, he had a small object tucked away in his hand. Izuku couldn't make out what it was. As Katsuki got back in the car, Izuku was about to ask him what was so important that caused him to drive like a bat out of hell but Katsuki beat him to it.

"Say cheese, nerd."

A giant flash went off quicker than Izuku could process. The blinding white light evoked a disgruntled groan from Izuku as tiny spots danced across his vision. He blinked rapidly and when his sight cleared up, he deeply frowned.

"A disposable camera?" Izuku questioned.

"Fuck yeah," his husband replied, a little too cheery. His toothy grin stretched wide with extreme pride. "Now we can have some pictures of all the different places of home. No matter what country we end up in."

"Okay…but when exactly are we going to take these pictures?"

"On our way to the safe house, duh," Katsuki explained like it was simple. "We're driving all the way across the country, might as well make the most of it."

Izuku was hesitant.

He liked the idea. But—

"—C'mon, darling," Katsuki pushed with a sweetness laced into his words. "Let's try to make some memories while we still can."

Katsuki tethered gazes with Izuku.

Like clockwork, Izuku was tempted by those dangerous scarlet eyes, yet again.

"Okay," Izuku agreed shyly. He smiled and melted into the fluttering sensation in his heart. "Let's do it."

ɯɯɯ

When they arrived at their first stop, Izuku was a bundle of nerves. He was holding on to Katsuki's arm and pulling their bodies close as they walked through the park. He was nervous they were veering off schedule, but Katsuki didn't seem the slightest bit worried.

With every step they took together Katsuki was reassuring him with a slight squeeze of his hand. As they pushed into the belly of the crowd they were surrounded by tourists far and wide but also one of the most tranquil parks Izuku had ever seen.

In the middle was a large, frozen lake and evergreen trees were littered all around them. Bunches of flowerless rose bushes were aligned along the corners with dead, yet beautiful, petals on top of the snow on the ground. Off to the side was the old traditional Japanese architecture that Izuku always loved. In the center was a bright red bridge over the frozen

lake. It was wide enough for two way foot traffic and gathered around were bunches of people, huddled like busy birds flying in and out.

Once they got close, Izuku saw that many of the people who were gathered were foreigners. They were blissfully happy on vacation, fluttering about and around snapping photos.

“That’ll be us soon,” Katsuki said to Izuku.

“On vacation?” Izuku laughed.

“Hell yeah.” Katsuki chuckled. “After all this we’re taking one *really* long fucking break. Now, let’s get in line to take one of those cheesy photos.”

They fell in line with the rest of the people, blending in well. Izuku watched curiously as the normal people took photos on the bridge, politely asking the previous person in line to take a photo of them with their loved one.

It was in this moment he observed different types of love all neatly lined up in such a simple way. He saw romantic love as a couple held each other and kissed for the camera. He saw parental love as a mother and daughter stood next to each other, hugging for the photo. Then finally he saw friendship—a group of college students all giggling as they posed with silly grins.

It was such a small thing: to take a picture with a loved one.

But it was something Izuku never had gotten to do before Katsuki.

At this thought, Izuku looked up at his husband fondly. Katsuki looked back down at him, flexing his eyebrows.

As Izuku studied his husband’s face, his eyes naturally wandered over Katsuki’s shoulder. He scanned the faces in the crowd apprehensively, but froze when he saw long, silver hair. Suddenly, a spike of adrenaline as painful as needles stabbed through him at the glimpse of the person.

The tall man was facing away from them, with menacing broad shoulders and his hair was pulled back into a sleek, all too familiar bun.

Izuku jolted and every nerve on his body was set aflame. His breath caught and he didn’t let it go. A hand tugged on Izuku’s arm, but he stayed frozen in place, eyes growing wide as the man began to turn.

“Izuku?” Katsuki called him.

Words could barely reach his ears as the man turned around to face them.

—but it was an unfamiliar face. Plain and unscarred.

“What’s wrong?” Katsuki’s voice turned deadly serious.

"…Nothing," Izuku whispered. He blinked rapidly several times to pull himself out of it. He sucked in several deep breaths and shook his head. "Sorry, I thought—I thought I saw someone but I was mistaken," Izuku whispered. "Sorry. False alarm."

Katsuki's eyes turned murderously sharp.

He gazed in the same direction as Izuku's on full alert. He scanned the area as if to be sure himself. When no one tripped Katsuki's deadly senses, Katsuki visibly relaxed. He then threw his arm around Izuku's shoulders and pulled him in close. His lips dipped to touch the shell of Izuku's ear.

"If you see anyone you even think is half suspicious, run," Katsuki whispered. "I meant it when I said I am your bodyguard. I'll make sure it's okay."

Izuku nodded quietly and Katsuki gave him another reassuring hug that melted away all the nerves he had gathered.

Katsuki asked the woman in front of them to take their photo and she agreed with a bright smile.

She took the disposable camera and it was then he and Katsuki posed. Izuku didn't know quite what to do, but Katsuki leaned into it so naturally. His husband tossed an arm around his shoulders and hugged him tightly. Izuku wrapped his arms around Katsuki's middle and leaned in. Right when they both said "cheese", Katsuki planted a chaste kiss right on Izuku's blushing cheek a second before the flash went off.

Izuku turned, surprised and Katsuki pinched his nose playfully.

"I like catching you off guard," Katsuki cheekily replied. "It's fun messing with you."

"You're more silly than I thought you were," Izuku laughed.

"You have a lot to still discover about me I guess," Katsuki replied. He laughed heartily and Izuku joined in the harmony.

When the next set of people asked them to take their photo, Katsuki happily agreed. He took the camera phone from an older man. Izuku stepped back politely and watched, and it was here Izuku noticed how much the two men looked alike. One was older, but not old enough to be the other's father. But when the two strangers joked warmly between each other, it struck Izuku what they were: brothers.

Izuku's face fell.

The two brothers playfully engaged in banter before posing and smiling together like they loved each other. Izuku was then reminded of a memory that was long buried in the back of his mind. It was shortly after Tomura began implementing their family dinners and long before his rise to total power.

The distant smell of sea salt reached Izuku's nose.

It had been such a small, simple day. There had been no mission. No blood. Tomura was bored and asked if Izuku wanted to come with him to a new tattoo parlor. Izuku had agreed because during this time, he didn't mind spending his days off with Tomura. They had taken a short day trip to the coast—

—and had taken a singular photo together on the beach.

Izuku realized he had stood corrected.

He had taken a photo with someone he loved before Katsuki.

But he was sure that version of Tomura no longer existed.



As they traveled, Izuku saw all the different versions of Tomura along the way.

He always questioned if Tomura truly loved him, or even cared about him as a person. But as he and Katsuki went place to place taking photos together, Izuku felt like he was finally able to see all the small moments he and Tomura shared together that were similar to this.

Ice cream shop trips. Dinners. Days Tomura let Izuku pick out his next snake tattoo.

There were so many tiny moments of affection that were hidden in Tomura's icy front. They showed like cracks that were too small to see with the naked eye, but as Izuku homed in on them he realized something largely important: Tomura could have easily been labeled as 'defective' as he was.

The singular difference was how his brother hid it. Tomura covered up his affections with cruelty. Every time he did something nice for Izuku, he doubled the amount of pain he inflicted.

This new realization was freeing like a weight had been cut from Izuku's ankles. Him and Tomura were alike, in the worst of ways. The montage of watching his brother grow up flashed in front of him, but this time without all the horror and blood. He saw the half smiles. The favoritism. The way his brother would quietly fuss over fixing his frizzy hair. He saw the intense looks of familial protectiveness.

It was all there, hidden in plain sight—and quite possibly the same, twisted reason Tomura had spent so much energy to set him up with Chisaki.

Then suddenly a soft hum from Katsuki lulled Izuku out of his thoughts.

He turned, and saw the angelic vision of Katsuki contrasted against the setting sun. Golden hair cradled the orange glow like a halo. Katsuki was zoned out driving, and was gently humming to the song on the radio.

His raspy voice was an octave off from the actual pitch, but he sounded so serene.

As he listened to Katsuki sing to the song, he felt Katsuki's love so clearly.

It wasn't hidden in cracks, and it was not overshadowed by any darkness that was inside of him. It was bright, warm and brought out the best version of Izuku.

Tomura's love never did that.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When the day felt like it was at its end, they found a secluded spot off the road. It was perfectly placed under the stars with the sound of the wind to keep them company.

They both huddled in the back seat, and cuddled for warmth. Izuku laid comfortably on top of Katsuki as he pulled the sleeping bag over them. Katsuki stroked his hair and then lightly kissed his forehead. When he tilted his head back, he sighed.

"Day one down," Katsuki grumbled as he closed his eyes. He wrapped his arms around Izuku's middle to keep him secure. "Two more to go until we're in the clear. It feels weird."

"Freedom is an elusive feeling—isn't it?" Izuku whispered.

"It is."

Izuku looked up at the stars that night and thought about love. Was it love that caused fate or was it fate that caused love? Because Tomura's version of love was control and Katsuki's version of love was freedom.

And Izuku's—

He was still learning what it was.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When they woke up the next day, it was Izuku's day to drive. They circled new pit stops on their map and a giddy feeling bubbled in Izuku's chest. They had taken so many pictures the day before they had to stop and get a new disposable camera. This time, Izuku was the one to happily buy it.

Their first pit stop this morning was a mountain. It stood tall like the embodiment of pride as it looked over the vast countryside. Izuku smiled as he hurried out the car and waved Katsuki along who was smiling as well. Izuku decided then and there to treat their new pit stops exactly like the foreigners from the bridge: a vacation.

He relaxed for the first time since the masquerade and let himself be lost in spending time with Katsuki. He learned a lot about His husband this way.

He learned when relaxed, his husband had a silly streak. He was playful like when they were kids and grumpy ever so slightly when things didn't go his way. He liked taking photos. Enjoyed the rain. Hated the snow. Secretly loved humming softly to himself.

Katsuki was an ever-unfolding mystery and Izuku was enjoying getting to know what Katsuki was like when he wasn't in high stress environments.

After several more pitstops, Izuku couldn't help but feel excited for the future.

ᔓᔓᔓ

The morning passed by without incident.

There were no threats lurking in the shadows as they made their way up to the central part of the country. They stopped off at a wine vineyard and took a picture together there. Then again in a large meadow. And again at a unique restaurant that sold different flavored almonds from Korea.

They were still on track for getting to the safe house in the time they had set out.

The long road they were on suddenly began filling up with larger villages, then small towns. The lonesome road transformed into winding bike trails, railroads and two way traffic much closer together.

Izuku eyed the bright white sign he drove past that read, "Welcome to Numata!"

They were close to passing Tokyo now, approaching the drop dead center of the country. It could have been paranoia, but Izuku swore he could feel Tomura's gaze coming from the east, searching for him.

Katsuki studied the welcome sign as well. He pulled out the map they had and uncapped their red sharpie with his mouth. He leaned back in his seat and spread the map wide in his hands.

"Halfway there. Thank fuck," Katsuki grumbled under his breath. "My back is starting to get a crick in it from sleeping in this cheap ass car. I'm too old for all of this."

Izuku stifled a laugh when Katsuki poorly attempted to crack his back. "You're not that old."

"Yeah yeah, I know. But my spirit is sixty," Katsuki jested. "All I know is there better be a warm bath waiting for us at this safe house—and a full plate of food or I'm going to lose my mind."

"Have you ever been where we're going?" Izuku asked curiously.

"No," Katsuki replied casually as he looked at something on the map. He took a sharpie and circled another tourist attraction. "The old man would never let me crash at one of his private properties. He's way too cagey."

"What about the other safe house?"

"What other safe house?" Katsuki answered, entirely distracted as he studied the map.

Izuku made a confused face. "The one that was on Oshima Island? That we had missed the ferry for?"

Katsuki paused. His eyes slowly rose from the map, as if he had forgotten all about that. Izuku was confused by the sudden onset of silence when Katsuki paused a beat too long to be written off.

“Right.” Katsuki’s voice was stiff—angry almost. “I’ve never been to that one either.”

Izuku’s brows knitted together. What was that?

Right when he was about to ask, Katsuki continued to speak.

“Um, Izuku,” Katsuki’s voice dropped below a whisper. “There’s something about that I’ve been…meaning to tell you.”

Izuku turned his gaze subtly to Katsuki, eyes off the road. He was stunned by the amount of sadness that was now in Katsuki’s face. Empathy was sitting in the front row, but above all—guilt was highlighted in his features. Katsuki hesitantly opened his mouth—but nothing came out. His eyes were scanning Izuku’s face as if trying to find the right words written in his freckles.

Izuku wasn’t looking at the road anymore. He felt oddly held in place.

Then for a second, Katsuki glanced in front of them. His eyes widened.

“Shit—Izuku!”

Izuku’s head turned fast enough to give himself whiplash. He exclaimed when he found them speeding towards a stopped car on the road. Izuku hit the brakes hard. Dramatically, they both toppled forward and the coffee that was in the cup holder spilled over. Katsuki cursed as he grabbed the dashboard and Izuku’s head snapped down at the sheer force.

They both sat in silence at the close call. Izuku perked his head up, glanced at Katsuki who was also relieved.

“Shit,” Izuku harshly whispered. “Sorry—I’m so sorry—”

“—Don’t worry about it,” Katsuki rapidly shook his head. “That was my fault.”

In front of them was an extremely long line of cars. Both husbands frowned deeply and straightened their backs on alert. It could simply be traffic, Izuku tried to reason. Or a tree that fell in the road like last time they got stuck like this. Izuku rolled down the window and peered his head into the winter winds to get a glimpse of what was going on.

It was a checkpoint.

Officers in blue were tediously checking driver’s licenses and cars on both sides of traffic. They flashed lights to the backseat and were instructing people to get out of their cars. Everyone who complied was let through very slowly.

Izuku felt the phantom sensation of Tomura’s hands gripping down on his shoulders. Whatever Katsuki had to say was brushed under the rug.

Izuku put on a serious face and hit the blinker. He made a sharp u-turn the way they came without a second thought. They turned off a side street and were able to shuffle back towards the way they came.

“The highway we need to get to the far north is on the other side of the checkpoint,” Izuku pointed out quietly. “Is there another way around?”

“Possibly,” Katsuki said. He frowned deeply when he saw one officer check the trunk of a car. He pulled out the map and looked closer at the tiny, twisting lines that were converging on the map. “Let’s keep driving west and see what we can find.”

Izuku glimpsed in the rearview mirror and saw one of the officers pat someone down far too thoroughly.

They were certainly searching for something—or someone.

ᔓᔓᔓ

They ended up finding themselves driving directly west—in the opposite direction of Tokyo.

They were getting off track now, and needed desperately to find a way through the middle of the country. However, every time they tried to even get past the threshold, they found themselves caught in another checkpoint that was conveniently blocking the access to the highways into any northern cities.

After the third checkpoint, Izuku no longer felt this was a coincidence.

“We’re going to have to ditch the car,” Katsuki said seriously. His eyes were sharply looking forward at the suspicious officers that were scanning IDs. “We’re not going to make it past like this.”

“I agree,” Izuku murmured quietly. “We need to find a town further south and take the train past Tokyo and as far north as possible.”

Katsuki nodded in agreement and immediately got to work. He looked at the map yet again and realized their route was officially null. He flipped the map over to reveal the train system guide and began to create a route through there. As he did this, Izuku narrowly u-turned back the way they came.

He peeked in his rear view again. However, this time instead of the police officers all not noticing, there was one who was looking straight at them.

A chill raked down Izuku’s spine.

The officer stood there like a statue, watching them drive away.

When the checkpoint was out of sight, the fear that had been pushed down inside of Izuku awoke. It stretched its limbs to take up room in his body and all he could feel was an ice cold terror. There was only one person on this planet that could make Izuku feel this way.

“Do you think your brother would put out checkpoints across the country to find you?” Katsuki asked uneasily.

Izuku didn’t reply back right away.

He could feel the glacial gaze of Tomura on his nape; it mimicked frost bite as it sunk into his flesh. The sensation overpowered him in a way that was saved for his Big Brother. The feeling was so prominent that Izuku could have sworn Tomura was in the car with them.

An imagined projection of Tomura appeared in the rear view mirror, like a ghost. His brother sat there with his legs crossed and hands in his pockets. His glare was soaked with venomous possessiveness. On either side of his phantom were the freshly slain Himiko and Jin, leering at him.

“He would do anything to find me,” Izuku whispered, all too sure.

ɯɯɯ

When they made it to a city away from the checkpoints, the couple considered their afternoon a wash. They were officially behind schedule. Getting to the safe house in two more days was slipping further and further away like grains of sand in an hourglass.

Currently, they were standing in some deserted parking lot in Toyama, Japan. They were parked right outside of the massive train station in the central part of the city.

The buildings in this city were tall, but not dense enough for Izuku to feel covered and safe. The vast open sky above them made him feel vulnerable. Almost as if Tomura’s watchful eye had more space to peer down and spot them.

Right now, Katsuki was leaning over the side of the car with the map. He had a green sharpie in one hand while staring hard enough at the map that he could burn holes in it. He was trying to figure out what trains they needed to take to make it to Mount Rausu. It was proving to be a complicated task because most trains in this part of the country filtered into Tokyo—and that was an absolute no-go for them.

“Alright—we can make it up to the old man in three days...four days tops,” Katsuki grumbled.

Well. That wasn’t what Izuku wanted to hear.

Katsuki gestured him over to take a look at the route he had crafted. Izuku gazed over the marked map and all the crossing lines nearly made him dizzy. Katsuki ran his gloved point finger from green dot to green dot explaining the transfers.

“First train we’re going to take is going to be four hours,” Katsuki said evenly. “It’ll drop us off in Niigata. Then after that, the next two trains are both eight hours. We’ll go from Niigata to Akita station, and from Akita station to Aomori. Then the final train we need to get on will be eleven hours. We’ll be dropped off at Shari.”

Izuku eyed the small distance between the last train stop and the mountain.

“And then we take a bus?” Izuku asked, pointing to the empty space.

“Unfortunately, no,” Katsuki huffed. “There’s no trains or buses in that part of the country based on this map. I think from the looks of it, we have to walk it. It’ll be exactly an eighteen hour walk on foot if we keep a good pace. But the trek up the mountain is going to be two hours at least.”

Izuku rubbed his forehead, the calculations were beginning to give him a migraine.

“But Niigata might be dangerous to pass through,” Izuku said seriously as he looked at their route. “That’s the Chisaki family’s original home city before they took over Tokyo.”

“Yeah. I remember you telling me. But there’s no other route that’s not through Tokyo, I’ve been trying to Tetris this shit together and there’s no other way.”

Izuku’s migraine pulsed. It was Tokyo or Niigata. They had to weigh it out—and truthfully Niigata was their best option.

When Izuku’s frown was too deep, Katsuki leaned in and planted a chaste kiss on his lips. Izuku felt himself flush and his frown was washed away despite his worries at that moment.

“Remember: we got this,” Katsuki reassured. He cradled Izuku’s face in his hands and chased his gaze down until they were locking eyes.

Izuku nodded.

They then began to get to work.

They grabbed their backpacks, securing the straps to their bodies tightly. Izuku pulled his black beanie over his hair and Katsuki placed sunglasses over his eyes. They both put on thin, black surgical masks and Izuku wrapped himself tightly in his red scarf. He sighed as he tried his best to tuck his unruly curls under the beanie but it was hard after two days without a comb and his siblings’ blood still mildly caked in his hair.

Katsuki gently tucked a lock under the beanie, helping him.

His husband then put his own baseball cap on and checked himself in the side mirror of the soon to be abandoned car. Katsuki pulled out the disposable camera and clicked his tongue to catch Izuku’s attention.

“Look this way, darling.”

Izuku didn’t have time to pose before the flash went off. He laughed while shaking his head, blushing slightly.

“I don’t think we get to play tourist anymore, Kacchan…”

“Definitely not, but that doesn’t mean I still can’t take photos,” Katsuki teased. “One day we’ll look back on these photos fondly.”

“Yeah,” Izuku whispered distantly as he looked at the train station. “One day.”

ᔓᔓᔓ

The first train was quaint and quiet, like most commutes. People had their heads down on their phones, or playing games on a handheld console. The seats on this train were a lime green color that felt like it glowed brighter with the early evening light.

Izuku and Katsuki found a pair of seats in the far back of the train. Izuku took the window seat while Katsuki was in the aisle. They chatted lightly and ate the snacks in their backpack along the way. Through this train they were able to see the ocean clear as day. The sunspots sparkled a bright white that reflected off the water, like a sea of tiny suns waving to them as they passed by.

Izuku leaned back on the window, enjoying the sun on his neck.

He pulled out the disposable camera and decided then to snap a quick photo of Katsuki in the seat next to him looking at the map. His husband looked extra concentrated. Eyes focused. Tongue sticking out. Izuku smiled lightly when Katsuki didn’t even register that he had his photo taken.

“What’s your supervisor like?” Izuku asked as his mind wandered.

“The bastard is grumpy as hell,” Katsuki quipped.

“So…like you?” Izuku compared cheekily.

Katsuki paused. He looked up from the map and cocked his head at Izuku. “Well. Yeah. I suppose that’s true.” Katsuki’s smirk twitched into a smile as he distantly lost himself to a memory. “I always thought I got my attitude from my mother, but I’m sure it was a combination of spending half my time with him too.”

“Makes sense, he was a big influence on you,” Izuku said.

“Y’know…one time, someone mistook us for father and son,” Katsuki offered up without being prompted.

“Really?”

“Mhm.” Katsuki snorted. “The person who thought that was a client. It was because the fucker had said some bullshit, and we both detected it at the same time. It was almost comical how we crossed our arms in sync.”

It was easy to picture: identical frowns that pulled on the sides of their mouths at the same time and then the duo folding arms. They probably both seemed so entirely unimpressed at the same time that DNA must’ve been the one explanation for the synchronization. Maybe

they even had the same forehead wrinkles from young Katsuki mirroring this guy's actions so much.

Izuku idly wondered if he and Tomura shared any of those similarities.

"Ah—Izuku," Katsuki chimed. He suddenly was sporting an extremely guilty expression. "Er. A couple of important things about my supervisor."

"What?"

"Well, first thing is his name is Aizawa, if you remember." Katsuki paused as if he was carefully sorting his next sentence. "The second thing is…he doesn't know exactly…how… bad the situation is. I told him about needing safety and all of that because I pissed off the Yakuza. But he doesn't know about us." Katsuki discreetly gestured between them with his finger. "Like—at all."

Izuku blinked.

He looked at the slightly rusted rings on their fingers.

"Nothing at all?" Izuku clarified.

"Nothing."

Izuku's chest twisted in a brief stir.

Katsuki was obviously ashamed as he explained, "I—I omitted you from my report about Okinawa. And I didn't mention you being at the estate with me. And…I didn't mention you in any of the voicemails."

Something about it stung. It was as if he was being pinched by the hands of inadequacy itself, but he should have known better. Aizawa had placed a kill order on his head this year—and Izuku didn't blame him.

"Sorry," Katsuki promptly amended. He reached his hand out, and laced their fingers together.

Izuku squeezed his hand back and tried his best to pin a smile to his lips. But it was half formed and clearly forced.

"No need to be sorry," Izuku finally spoke. His voice was rusty as he pushed the words out of his mouth. "I, uh, would do the same if I was in your shoes."

"But I really am sorry how I've handled all of this shit," Katsuki pushed, deeply sincere. "What I'm trying to say is, let me talk to him first, okay? If he sees you, he might flip out and get the wrong assessment of the situation. When we get to the mountain I'll take the lead and talk with the old man before he goes off the rails."

Izuku nodded and forced a smile. "Okay."

Katsuki pulled his mask down, kissed his forehead, and went back to gazing at the map.

Izuku found himself daydreaming about meeting Aizawa. He wondered what the man was like. Did he laugh similar to Katsuki? How many qualities did they share, and exactly how important was his opinion to his husband? Izuku chewed on his bottom lip apprehensively.

He couldn't help but want to make a good impression, but that ship might've sailed. Tiredly, Izuku leaned his head against Katsuki's shoulder. His skull became bogged down by all the buzzing thoughts filling it up.

Izuku's gaze stayed glued on their rings.



The first train ride went by with a bat of an eye. He and Katsuki were in and out of sleep the whole time. Every time Izuku awoke, he found more snow outside their train window as they ventured further and further north.

The second train ride dragged much slower.

They were boxed in a red cart that stunk mildly of cigarettes. It made his nose itch and then about half way through, a man next to them began eating a bag of potato chips obnoxiously loud. Izuku could've wrangled the man for the impolite chewing but they both had to endure it. He and Katsuki were trying their best to sleep as much as they could and retain any energy they needed in case something occurred.

However, there was a finite amount of quality sleep they could get in the old leather seats.

At some point during the eight hour ride, the two husbands played tic-tac-toe what felt like a thousand times over. Izuku learned Katsuki was oddly good at the game, and he was also good at rock paper scissors, which made Izuku flustered to lose several rounds in a row.

By the end of the second train, Izuku gained a crick in his back that was the same as his husband.

Now, they were running to make their third train.

It was somehow already the day's end and the last train leaving out of the station took off as soon as they ran down onto the platform.

"Hurry!" Katsuki shouted as he instantly broke into a sprint.

Izuku caught up to him and passed him as they both ran for the train. They could see the doors begin to shut and for a split second, Izuku thought they could make it. They got inches away—and then the metallic doors slammed shut directly in his face.

"Damnit!" Izuku yelled as he collided with the closed doors.

His hands touched the cold surface and slowly, the steel beast began to pull off. Katsuki groaned and threw his head back as he slowed his running.

Izuku pursed his lips as he watched their train leave them behind.

“Well…that’s the last train until 6:00 am,” Katsuki grumbled. “We’re stuck for the night.”

Izuku’s eyes looked up above at the giant golden clock. It was exactly 00:00am. They had six hours.

Katsuki’s loud sigh bounced off the concrete walls of the underground platform. He took off his backpack and placed it down on the cold ground next to the tracks. He sat down like he was weighed down by rocks in his pockets with a loud thump. Tiredly, the young blond leaned his body against one of the pillars.

Izuku followed suit and stretched out his legs across the cold ground. He pulled his face mask down for fresh air when he noticed they were completely alone.

Izuku took a moment of silence to look around. He gazed up at the low ceiling that held the beautiful old golden clock. Its hands were an intricate type of black metal and the numbers were roman numerals. The platform was decorated sort of the same, something of a relic from the industrial times with stark white tiles, gold lining and old chipped paint.

The air inside of the platform was cool, and the station was eerily quiet. The sole sounds were the occasional creak of old wooden benches and the soft whistle of the wind through the cracked windows. The empty platform stretched ahead, dimly lit by the glow of a single flickering light.

“How is your back doing? Should we try to find a hotel?” Izuku asked.

Katsuki shook his head and said, “No hotels. My back is just going to have to suffer.”

“Well...guess it’s only us and the night, huh?” Izuku mused. He decided to try to find the silver lining. He smiled at Katsuki who softly gazed at him. “Y’know, this isn’t so bad. It’s kinda romantic in a weird, deserted way.”

Katsuki scoffed. “Of course you would find this place to be romantic.”

“What? It is!” Izuku defended with a smile. His dimples showed as he sat up right more. “I mean look around. The pillars are numbered with fancy old steel that was likely hand carved by someone. It must’ve taken a lot of passion to do something like that.”

Katsuki raised an eyebrow. He assessed the number 4 on the pillar across from them and admired the small flower symbol that was hidden in the design.

“Huh. I guess you’re right,” Katsuki agreed. “Well. With that attitude I guess this is an adventure then, isn’t it? We could do whatever we want.”

Izuku shook his head when Katsuki smirked mischievously. “I didn’t say all of that.”

“Yeah, but you implied it,” Katsuki teased. He winked as he leaned in closer to his husband. Heat rolled off Katsuki’s skin and Izuku blushed automatically from the proximity. “The station’s ours for the night. No one else to disturb us. And look at that sky—” Katsuki paused to gesture to the window where the moon was barely visible above the horizon. “We’ve got a front-row seat to the stars, darling. We could have some real fun.”

Izuku glanced up at the sky for a moment, and the corners of his mouth turned further up.

“Okay, I’ll give you that,” Izuku said. “What adventure do you want to have for six hours?”

“Your Captain Romance,” Katsuki shot back. “This should be a perfect opportunity for one of your ‘lessons in love’. What do you think we should do?”

Izuku glanced around the station with a thoughtful expression. The wind made a howling sound, rattling the old building and the benches creaked in tandem with the shift.

Izuku pursed his lips and muttered, “I don’t know.”

“Really? You don’t know?”

“No, I’m sorry, Kacchan. I’m all out of romantic ideas, I guess.”

“Well, I thought the answer would be obvious, dork.” Katsuki stood up and took off his baseball cap. He shook out his messy hair and stood in front of Izuku with his hands on his hips. A charming smirk caught his lips. “I think we have no choice but to dance.”

Izuku blanched.

He laughed awkwardly at first, short and not serious. But when Katsuki didn’t budge Izuku laughed nervously even more. He looked around the ghost station with a confused face.

“Dance?” Izuku reaffirmed. “Here? Me and you?”

“Duh,” Katsuki said, not budging an inch. “Come on, one little dance, I promise I won’t make you look stupid.”

Izuku was still unsure.

“I owe you one,” Katsuki added, much more serious. “Last time wasn’t correct.”

Izuku thought back to the last time they danced—it was the masquerade.

He quietly realized why Katsuki wanted to do this.

Izuku nodded gingerly. “Okay. Let’s dance.”

He rose to his feet and lightly brushed off the back of his pants. He slowly removed his beanie, loving the feeling of the air on his scalp after nearly twelve hours. Izuku let Katsuki gently guide them into the middle of the empty platform.

The cool air swirled around them, letting them know they were alone. A full contrast to last time with all the prying eyes of the Yakuza watching their every move. Now, it was nothing but the two of them and the warmth between them that made the night feel cozy, like it belonged to them.

Katsuki started the sway and Izuku's imagination transformed the room.

The old pillars were now made of expensive white granite, and decorated like they were in a fancy ballroom. A lavish, chestnut floor was beneath their feet and they weren't wearing dingy jackets but rather clean, crisp suits with delicate blouses underneath.

Katsuki then hummed a quiet, off-beat tune. But then slowly the melody shifted until it took form. The soft, ethereal hum drifted into the air and the first few notes were instantly recognizable. Izuku's eyes widened, and he couldn't help but giggle, shaking his head at the sheer irony.

"Really, Kacchan? My Heart Will Go On?"

Katsuki replied with a shrug as he continued to hum. "You're the one who is such a nerd about it. I thought you might like it."

Izuku laughed deeply, directly from his belly. He pictured them together back in Love's Paradise on the boat awkwardly swaying to the song. It seemed like a lifetime ago now, and here Katsuki was—willingly—humming it.

Katsuki continued to hum the song before singing it. He wrapped his arms around Izuku and continued to dance them around. Izuku laughed, breaking the beat, but then he joined in.

Katsuki sweetly sang, "Love can touch us one time—"

"—And last for a lifetime," Izuku sang back, smiling brightly. "And never let go 'til we're gone…"

They continue to sing the song together, the lyrics filling the space around them.

Izuku soaked in this moment, appreciating their blending in such a gentle harmony. It was a little off-key, but it didn't matter. In this carefree moment, the music was theirs, floating through the quiet station, wrapping around them like a familiar embrace.

As the iconic refrain raised, so did their voices.

They jointly sang—"Near…far…wherever you are,"—they held each other a little tighter, letting the lyrics remind them of everything they meant to each other. They continued to let their voices rise, and got louder as they danced together, lost in the night. Their steps on the platform felt like the tempo they always were searching for.

Then in perfect unison, they both belted out, "You're here, and there's nothing I fear—" Their singing was cut up with laughter as they continued, unabashed, "And I know that my heart will go on! We'll stay *forever* this way!"

Izuku's voice trailed off but Katsuki's continued as he whispered the lyrics, "You are safe in my heart and my heart will go on and on…"

Then, the two of them stop their singing. It came to a gentle halt and the lyrics were replaced by Katsuki's gentle hum of the rift.

The world around them was now a quiet, private sanctuary for the two of them. Their steps became more fluid, more natural. The night continued to stretch on, but it felt like time had slowed down for them. There was something deeply intimate in the way they shared this moment—two people, moving in sync, creating their own rhythm in an otherwise deserted place.

"This is kind of amazing," Katsuki whispered. He tilted his head, impressed with the two of them like they deserved a prize. "Who else gets to slow dance to the Titanic theme song at midnight in a train station?"

"Only us," Izuku replied with a chuckle. His eyes set at half mast as he gazed at his husband. "Despite everything, Kacchan…I-I wouldn't want to be anywhere else right now."

At this proximity, Izuku could feel Katsuki's heart speed up.

Then Katsuki's eyes softened and he pulled Izuku impossibly closer. He placed their foreheads together as he whispered delicately.

"Near, far…wherever you are," Katsuki muttered, as if the Céline Dion lyrics were truly a match for his feelings. "I'll always be here…Izuku. Wherever you go, I will go. I will always make my way back to you. Over and over and over. I mean it."

Izuku's heart softened hearing their vows again. He leaned back as they shared a leveled look, deeply staring into the other's gaze. Izuku's heart fluttered. He leaned in slowly and so did Katsuki. They both closed their eyes to share a kiss. It was full of love so pure Izuku was sure he almost felt cleansed of his past.

They stopped swaying, and time stood still for them for a generous moment.

When they broke apart, their eyes were inseparable. Deeper and deeper into their passionate love they fell. One right after the other—head first both tumbling down and down.

"Always, huh?" Izuku whispered, heart racing at a high. "Even when we're stuck in random train stations in the middle of nowhere?"

"Especially then." Katsuki laughed. "I'll dance with you anywhere, any time, darling. As long as we're together."

"You've got a deal. But it seems like we've always been together," Izuku said thoughtfully. "Even when we didn't know it."

Katsuki smiled at that. "Yeah, it does, doesn't it? It almost kind of feels like…"

Fate.

Izuku waited for Katsuki to say that word once more.

But it didn't come and Izuku didn't finish the sentence. Izuku knew Katsuki didn't believe in fate, and lately Izuku wondered if he did anymore. However, what he did believe in was Katsuki. He believed in this moment, and he believed in them making it to safety together.

They continue swaying, and they resume their humming.

The song wrapped around them like a soft, familiar blanket. There was no rush. At this rate, Izuku feared the world could pass them by and they wouldn't even notice. This moment was all that mattered. The slow, steady rhythm of their hearts. The hum of a love song, and the warmth of each other's presence.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When morning came, she came bearing bright rays of light that stirred Izuku and Katsuki awake from sleeping on the platform floor. The echo of footsteps on the stairs woke them up as the busy people of Akita Station filled the platform to begin their days.

Izuku could feel the tax of day three on the run in his muscles and in the pits of his stomach.

They both put back on their hats and surgical masks and zoned in.

"Alright, last two trains and then we hike—after that, we're in the clear," Katsuki said, fully hopeful.

They boarded the six a.m. train and on the way in, Izuku naturally scanned all the people piling in with them. Many were adults and middle aged men and women in suits. Some others were families looking as if they were heading to a wintry vacation. Others looked like they were getting in from a late night and merely wanted to go home.

As Izuku and Katsuki made their way to the back of the train, Izuku spotted an elderly man with a large hunchback who caught his eye.

The man had wrinkles that stretched across his face and a handful of moles that were interestingly arranged. The tiny black dots created a loose shape of a heart on his left cheek. His eyes were a warm, mahogany brown that was very inviting—and they were locked right on Izuku.

Izuku didn't smile at first. But when the elder man gave him a sweet wave with his cane, Izuku felt himself give in. He hesitantly, but shyly waved back as he passed by. Heat gathered in his chest at the simple action, he felt like such a normal civilian for the first time.

They entered the next cart and found two perfect seats waiting for them.

They plopped down and sighed at the feeling of old leather.

"Much better than the ground," Katsuki laughed. He shifted until he was comfortable and then pulled out a tiny sheet of paper. He took out his black pen and smirked at Izuku. "Ready

to lose in tic-tac-toe again, nerd?"

Izuku shook his head and put his hands up. "I'll play if we make it best out of one hundred. At least I'll have a shot at winning."

"Sure, but that's still not going to stop you from losing."

ᔓᔓᔓ

It didn't.

By the end of the eight hour train ride, Izuku had somehow lost 15 to 85 games of tic-tac-toe.

"How do you keep doing that?" Izuku groaned, flabbergasted. He stared at the tiny Xs and Os like there must've been a secret formula.

Katsuki gave no answer to his witchcraft besides a sharp, sarcastic chuckle.

They gathered their bags when the train came to a full halt. When they stood up, they wordlessly held hands. Together the two husbands helped maneuver through the dense crowd at Aomori station. As the train emptied out on the platform, over hundreds of bodies shuffled with them. People zig zagged like tiny ants in overlapping lines trying to get where they were going.

When they found their last train—hope dared to bubble in Izuku's stomach.

The train was larger than the others they had been on, and was much newer. It had a sleek silver look to it with two black parallel lines that cut across the middle. It was one of the fancier trains that was better built for extreme distances.

Right before they boarded, Izuku caught sight of the large giant four faced clock overhead.

It was nearly 14:00, which meant they would get to Shari, Japan at exactly 01:00.

When they boarded, they did their usual routine and headed for the back of the train. However, when they arrived they found it was packed to the brim with people. Izuku frowned, but he supposed that it was normal for this time of the day. Katsuki jutted his head back towards the front of the train and they wandered by to the middle section.

They were lucky enough to find two empty seats and staked their claim.

Right as Izuku shuffled into the window, he casually scanned the crowd in the cart. He saw a couple of similar faces, many of which were on the last train with them. Izuku noticed a mom who had been behind them in line at the last stop and the elderly man with the heart shaped moles who had waved at him.

"Eleven more hours to go," Katsuki said sardonically. "Do you feel like getting whooped in tic-tac-toe again?"

“No, I do not,” Izuku chuckled and shook his head. “You can play by yourself, I’m sure that would be far more entertaining to you.”

“Ouch. Someone’s a sore loser. Didn’t think you would be that type, darling.”

Izuku sheepishly smiled and confessed, “I’m actually tired.”

At that Katsuki shifted down in the cushiony seat further. He smiled at Izuku from underneath his surgical mask and quietly wrapped an arm around him. Izuku naturally nuzzled in, leaning into his husband’s body heat.

“Go ahead and sleep then,” Katsuki said sweetly. “We both honestly should try to. We’re going to need our strength for the day hike we have to do after this.”

Izuku nodded and closed his eyes. It was here the train began to take off, and the roaring sound of wheels against the rails filled the air.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When Izuku roused awake, the attrition of being on the run was weighing him down.

All of his adrenaline must’ve seeped through his skin during his deep sleep, because now he could feel pure physical exhaustion from the last two weeks. Every overwhelming encounter piled on top of the next, making all the damage he’s sustained amplified. Izuku rolled his neck when he could feel his arms pulse around the still healing bullet wounds, nicks, and deep cuts. The ones that stung the most he knew were fresh from Himiko and Jin.

Izuku’s eyes blinked open slowly and all his senses came in.

The first sound that breached his ears was Katsuki’s snoring. His husband was out like a light, huddled up to him with his head dropped back against the seat. His arms were locked around Izuku’s midsection and his legs were stretched out wide.

Izuku sat up straight and noted it was dark outside. The sun had returned to her cozy home beneath the horizon, leaving behind the stars in her trail. His eyes slid over to the electric clock at the front of the cart and he could see it was now officially 23:07.

Wow. He had slept eight straight hours.

Izuku looked around and noticed barely anyone was in the cart. In fact, it seemed like it was only them and the old man with the heart shaped mole pattern. The elderly man was snoring loudly with his head lulled between his shoulders as he clutched on to his cane for support.

Izuku shifted and the action immediately roused Katsuki.

A long, deep groan spilled from his husband.

“Damn,” Katsuki grumbled, voice full of gravel. “What time is it?”

“It’s 23:07,” Izuku answered. “We have two hours left.”

Katsuki yawned and worked out his neck. He nodded tiredly and slowly sat up straight. He craned his head to take a look around at the empty cart.

“Interesting.” Katsuki rubbed his eyes. “No one is traveling this far north?”

Izuku shrugged. He was about to give his own opinion, but it was cut short by the sudden gentle push on his bladder.

“Ah. I have to pee,” Izuku announced quietly.

Katsuki nodded and stood up to let him out. As Izuku squeezed his way into the aisle, he walked towards the tiny bathroom nook. It was a few seats ahead of them. He looked behind him to see Katsuki had his eyes open, paying him very close attention.

Izuku passed by the sleeping elderly man.

Then out of nowhere, a scalding jolt of pain hit him as a needle punctured the back of his leg.

Time slowed as heat radiated from where he was hit, and the sting raced down his leg. Immediately, his limb nearly went numb and Izuku toppled forward before he could comprehend what happened. He loudly hit the ground with a yelp and whirled around to look at his assailant. There, he found the once warm eyes of the elderly man to be cold and deadly.

It was only from this angle did Izuku see the faded Shie Hassaikai tattoo that was hidden on the man’s rubbery neck.

In the blink of an eye, everything sped back up.

Katsuki screamed his name and made a run for him. Izuku tried to scramble upright, and as soon as he did, both doors on either side of the cart snapped open. Like a tsunami, eight men dressed in all black came pouring in, four from each end.

“Katsuki, watch out!” Izuku screamed as the four men began to draw their weapons.

Katsuki instantly drew his knife from his holster and began fighting on the defensive. The men tried to punch, kick, and hold him down. But Katsuki’s strength thwarted them in a flurry.

Hands grappled at him from all over as Katsuki did his best to hold his own. In a fury of unrelenting paced moves, Katsuki blocked, dodged, and landed several painful punches directly in their faces. With an air slicing movement, he successfully landed his blade into the side of one man. The guttural scream the man let out bounced off the walls as Katsuki lanced his blade in the side of another man’s neck.

It all swirled together.

Izuku was trying to fight off the ambush despite the paralyzer pumping in his veins. He landed a handful of successful pressure point punches aimed precisely at their cores. The bodies fell. But then they got back up—like they were being puppeteered by forces unseen.

Izuku's killer instinct sharpened as he landed one sickening kick to the jaw of one of the men. The man toppled straight down on the flat on his back and blood sprayed across the windows.

Then a loud, metal slam echoed through the cart. Izuku glanced back for a split second.

There he found Katsuki, back against the wall, fighting off the two remaining men on him.

Katsuki was holding the barrel of one of his enemy's guns, using all his strength to keep it pointed away from him. He kept it aimed in the air all while trying to avoid being slashed by the other man. The three men were caught in an intense three way dance of ducking, dodging, and trying to land a deadly blow.

Izuku's heart began to race higher. His adrenaline pushed against the exhaustion and tranquilizer that was coursing through his blood. Izuku's nostrils flared as he forced himself into overdrive. He picked up his speed. He worked like liquid lightning as he began his best to maneuver being captured by the men. He grabbed for his blade that was tucked into his waistband. Then he spun wide, slicing two of the men.

One man held his neck as his artery was cut. The other dodged and left with a shallow wound. Izuku pushed forward on the three men with a vicious barrage of knife attacks, backing them into the corner. He was gaining speed—until he wasn't.

Sharp, sudden pain shot through Izuku from his puncture wound.

He stumbled. His capturers saw the opening like sharks. They pushed in and took the advantage. Izuku tried to go on the defensive—but another blinding shot of pain hammered into his leg.

Izuku yelled as his muscles cramped on themselves. The tranquilizer in his leg was working its way through his body swiftly now—his resistance to the substance had been slowing it down. However, it wasn't slowing it down enough any more.

He tried to run. He turned, and headed straight for his husband for help.

But he cursed loudly when he reached Katsuki and found himself eating the carpeted floor of the train. His leg now felt like cement. Unmoving. Then came another sharp, unkind jab that pierced his other leg. The liquid burned so intensely that it ripped a scream from his lips that caused the whole cart to reverberate.

Katsuki snapped his head towards him and it was a mistake.

The small opening was enough for one burly man to put Katsuki in a drop dead headlock. Katsuki choked. He sunk his nails into the man's arm—piercing the skin until it drew blood. He tried to throw the man off of him. But every time he attempted the man leaned back, restraining Katsuki in a bind.

Izuku used all his strength to try to stand up, but failed when two men grabbed him by both of his arms. They twisted his appendages unnaturally and forced Izuku to drop his weapon.

They had him locked in a bruising hold, restraining him fully with all their body weight. They hoisted him roughly off the ground and held him up in the air.

Izuku struggled against them. He tried to get to Katsuki. But as the paralyzer took root in his body, both of his legs stopped responding to him.

They were as good as dead weight.

Izuku continued to fight against the men, eyes wide with fear as he looked at Katsuki in front of him.

Katsuki's eyes were wild like a feral beast. His nose was flared and his teeth were barred. He tried to shake the man off of him with several punches but when another man walked up and landed a catastrophic gut punch to Katsuki's center, it cut him down.

Blood spilled from Katsuki's lips and he began to violently cough.

Slowly, in the midst of the chaos, the elderly man stood up. The hunch in his back completely disappeared, and he unsheathed his cane to reveal a thin, golden sword that was inside. He straightened out his shirt and his once harmless aura evaporated into the air.

He glared at Katsuki like he was an insect.

"Chisaki sends his regards," the elderly man said. "Enjoy your last night on this earth, Bakugou Katsuki. In the next lifetime, know it's impossible to ever get the upper hand on the Yakuza Heir."

He snapped his fingers and the two lovers were dragged in opposite directions.

Izuku began to kick. Scream. Scratch and bite the best he could as his whole lower half betrayed him. Tears blurred his vision as he watched Katsuki struggle with all his might against the men who piled on him like flies. They forcefully took him and Izuku's heart began to break. It broke down and down until it was in a thousand shards shredding him apart from the inside.

"Kacchan!" Izuku screamed.

In a violent twist, Izuku tore one of his arms free. He reached out for Katsuki.

Katsuki's eyes widened, and his pupils constricted.

Izuku screamed as his arm was lurched backwards into a binding hold. The two men dragged him away towards the back of the train. The automatic door opened and they hauled Izuku out of the cart. As the doors slid shut, Izuku could see Katsuki be lugged away into the opposite cart.

Izuku floundered more, and his heart pumped adrenaline through him. He could feel his body reach down into the pits of his stomach and unlock his overdrive—but in an instant he was hit again with another syringe. This time, it was in the neck.

Izuku's body seized up as his world began to fade to black.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku went in and out.

He was here. Then he wasn't.

The toxin in his body was fighting his immune system. He had been overloaded past what a normal dosage would be and it left him feeling queasy. His memory began to form in patches that rotated between understanding what was happening and blank spaces.

He registered when he was dragged through the train. There was no one else on the carts. Then he went into blackness again.

He registered being unceremoniously tossed on the ground in the baggage cart. Then more blackness. Then he registered the two large men above him, leering. They pulled out their phones and began to make calls.

Then once more, Izuku fell to the shadows for an extended period.

When Izuku came to again, his body was on fire and he was severely disoriented. The world faded in from black and dizziness hit the pits of his stomach. Nausea rocked its way up through his stomach to his nose as his head pulsated a deadly tempo.

Izuku tried to scream but his mouth was sloppily duct taped.

Next, Izuku tried to move but was restricted.

He frantically began squirming and found painful zip ties cutting into his wrists. He hissed as he tried to move his arms but it was fruitless. He was bound by rope that was securely laced around his chest, arms, thighs, legs, and ankles.

His shaky vision scanned everywhere in the room. The baggage cart was small, red, and it wasn't meant for sitting. The door on this cart was a large metal door that was clearly designed to keep people out—or in this case, keep someone in.

Izuku continued to scan the room until he found two goons standing above him. They were ruffled up, nursing broken noses and deep cuts on their arms. One guy was tall with crimson hair and the other had eyes as striking as the sea.

Both of them homed their lethal gazes on Izuku.

"Ah. The prize is awake," the redhead goon spoke.

The other with ice blue eyes scoffed. With a confused stare he asked, "How is that possible? It hasn't even been thirty minutes and we gave him triple the dosage of that shit. He should be out for the next several days."

“It’s because he’s a viper. You know those fuckers eat poison for breakfast. His body probably metabolizes toxins quicker than a goddamn machine.” The man then leaned down into Izuku’s face and sneered. In a frustrated voice he asked, “You’ve caused a lot of trouble. Do you know that, sweetheart?”

Izuku didn’t respond. He viciously glared at his kidnapper, holding back tears as his mind couldn’t stop worrying about Katsuki. Where was Katsuki—

“Honestly, after looking at him up close—I get it,” the blue eyed man said. He leaned back against the wall and let his eyes roam over Izuku. “If I was Chisaki, I would launch one thousand ships for that face too.”

“Yeah, he’s a looker. But it’s unfortunate he stirred up this much chaos. Everyone’s damn vacation time got canceled.”

“It’s whatever now. After we dispose of that blond, all of this will be over.”

Izuku froze.

The blue eyed man sinisterly smirked and chuckled, “Ah, that seemed to get a reaction out of him.”

“Yeah, sorry about that, sweetheart. Your little runaway lover is being cut up in tiny pieces as we speak.”

The two men laughed and Izuku’s heart plummeted through the center of the earth.

No.

No. No. No.

He shook his head to try to jostle himself out of this nightmare. But it wasn’t working. He stayed tied up, forced to listen to the maniacal laughter of the two thugs in front of him.

The heavy metal door slid open slowly.

The sound of hefty machinery scraped the sound waves in the room as the elderly man from earlier walked in. He no longer had his cane and Izuku felt fury stir within him. The two goons straightened out, making it clear of the hierarchy that was between this unit of killers.

“They’re finishing the job,” the elderly man spoke. His voice was deep and leveled. “After they come back, we should be good to go. One of you, inform The Horned Viper and let him know we caught his brother. We’ll meet him at the next train stop in Bihoro.”

One of the men began to dial someone on a flip phone. The other leaned against the wall. Then finally the elderly man pressed close on the sliding door.

Izuku screwed his eyes shut.

This can’t—this can’t happen. Katsuki can’t be—

But before the door could shut, a veiny hand covered in blood shot out and caught it.

The red stained fingers dug into the steel and forced the sliding door back the way it came. The mechanics snapped from the sheer strength of the hand as it was forced against its mechanism. In the dark room, Izuku could see the glint of the green gem on the ring finger.

“Wh-What the hell?!” One of the men yelled and reached for his gun.

The door snapped open violently, breaking in the process.

It happened quicker than anyone could see. A blur of black and blond hair rushed into the room.

Katsuki slammed his body into the biggest goon and immediately disarmed him of his gun. The two other thugs in the room tried to shoot him. They fired off several bullets—and failed when Katsuki twisted the larger body in front of him as a shield. The man was pumped with lead and his eyes rolled back. Katsuki held the body up as he used it to cover himself.

A savage snarl took over his face as his scarlet red eyes glowed in the moonlight.

He took the gun and shot the second goon square in the forehead.

The body dropped and the elderly Yakuza man tried to run. But Katsuki grabbed him ferociously. With all his strength, Katsuki tossed the man hard into the wall, shaking the cart. Katsuki then threw a staggering punch directly to the man’s face. His knuckles cut across the man’s teeth and blood sprayed onto the walls.

The older gangster tried to pull out his gun but Katsuki broke his wrist. He snapped it back unnaturally in the blink of an eye. The weapon dropped to the ground with a heavy thud and Katsuki pinned the man to the wall.

Katsuki brandished his blade.

“N-No,” the man whispered and began struggling more. “Get your filthy hands off of me! I’m a high ranking Yakuza! You’ll regret this! Chisaki will make sure you die a slow and painful death for this—”

Katsuki leaned in cruelly and his eyes swarmed with shadows. He placed his blade on the man’s bobbing throat and pushed.

“Chisaki will never get the upper hand on me because I have the one thing he doesn’t,” Katsuki hissed. His voice dragged in the same way his knife did across the man’s throat. “I have killer instincts.”

Blood poured down the man’s neck and he began gasping for life. The body floundered before it dropped. Katsuki stepped back and allowed it to hit the ground with the other two bodies in the enclosed space.

Silence enveloped the cart.

The aura spilling off Katsuki chilled Izuku down to the bones.

His head was dropped down, and blood was caked into his blond hair. The red liquid dripped like rain from his head and down his coat to his leather boots. It was everywhere. When he lifted his gaze, the shadow over his face darkened his features to be as terrifying as the beast inside of him.

Scarlet eyes cut over to Izuku.

Izuku's heart skipped a terrible beat.

Wordlessly, Katsuki urgently bent down. He reached for the duck tape and gently peeled it off. He chucked it to the side and began to work quickly. He turned Izuku on his belly and began to cut him free from the rope with his bloody blade.

Izuku exhaled a long, shaky breath as he felt himself set free.

"Are you okay?" Katsuki asked as his eyes darted all over Izuku's body. "Did they hurt you?"

"No, I'm okay," Izuku replied.

Katsuki gave one short, curt nod back before he helped Izuku to his feet. Izuku wobbled, and his legs protested against him as he rose. He groaned when he could feel the burning numbness in his legs. The toxin wasn't dispelling as quickly as it used to.

Katsuki immediately picked up on this and hoisted Izuku up. He slung Izuku's arm over his shoulders and gripped him by the waist for support. He helped Izuku to the door and the two of them limped out of the baggage cart with haste.

When they came into the light of the passenger carts, the two husbands felt the pressure of time against their necks. Urgency to get the hell off this train had officially been applied. They first went for their backpacks—and along the way a trail of dead bodies were splayed across the floor. There was blood staining the carpet, and Izuku tried his best not to trip as he stepped over every cold corpse. One. Two. Four. Seven.

Katsuki had cut down every single person who stood in his way.

They grabbed their backpacks hastily and secured them to their bodies. Not bothering with their masks or hats, they made a run for it back to the end of the train.

When they made it back to the baggage cart, Katsuki flung open the emergency door and a harsh gust of wind tore into them. Izuku used his arm to shield his eyes and Katsuki grabbed him by the waist to steady their balance. Both husbands gripped the lips of the exit as they wearily looked out the train. The wind picked up as if it was screaming for them to run.

The train was moving at full speed. It rounded the corner of a small mountain, dipping low as it hugged the side. There was a breadth of room between the train and the sharp, hard rock of the mountain as the steel beast went down the decline. All Izuku could see zooming by them at high speeds were snow and pine trees.

They both looked at each other and the winds picked up.

“It’ll be like jumping into a soft cloud,” Katsuki tried to reassure. “The snow will break our fall.”

Izuku wearily replied back, “That’s a myth. It’s going to burn.”

The rhythmic clatter of the train’s wheels against the tracks was suddenly drowned by the deafening sound of heavy boots on steel. The baggage car door flew open with a violent crash, revealing the hulking figures of several more Yakuza. Izuku’s adrenaline spiked when he got a glimpse of their guns.

The Yakuza shouted and pointed towards them on the opposite end of the cart and began running towards them at full speed.

“Let’s go—” Katsuki hissed.

Izuku’s heart pounded in his ears.

The sound of Yakuza men shouting at them grew louder, closer. Katsuki squeezed Izuku’s hand one last time, and he tied their gazes together. At that moment, it was just them. The two of them against the world.

They jumped.

The cold air hit like a wall, biting into their skin as they fell, the world a blur of steel and snow, a violent whirlwind. For a heartbeat, time seemed to slow. Izuku’s stomach lurched as the ground rushed up to meet them, and then—

Snow.

At this speed, it seared into their skin and the feeling of ice against his cheek burned. They rolled chaotically and Izuku’s vision became a rotation of black sky and white snow. He went down the hill, gaining speed. He gritted his teeth as he continued to roll, mentally noting that Katsuki was partially correct. It was like landing in a half-soft cloud—the other half was like tiny blades of ice.

They tumbled down the incline. Then slowly, they rolled until they came to a soft stop. Izuku grunted when Katsuki’s body collided with his and his husband’s arms found their way around him protectively. Together, they skidded in the pile of soft powder.

They both looked up, breathless but alive.

Izuku laid there for a moment. Blistering pain was sounding alarm bells through his legs. The thick air mixed with the sound of Katsuki’s ragged breaths. Izuku closed his eyes when the world kept spinning.

Katsuki leaned up and hovered over him.

Soft, scarlet eyes studied him while snow decorated his husband’s blond hair.

“Are you okay?” Katsuki asked, his voice hoarse.

Izuku groaned but managed a small, exhausted nod. “Never better.”

They both stumbled to their feet and Katsuki pulled Izuku upright with ease. Izuku wobbled and leaned in fully to Katsuki when his legs began to shake. His husband caught his weight and the two of them looked up to the train.

It was barreling away from them at high speeds into the night. The rickety sound of the track cranked on and the steel beast left a thick cloud of smog in its wake.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Wherever they were, it was on top of a mountain that was laced with thick pine trees. Izuku could smell the light scent tickle his nose. The winds up here were sharper, cutting through the poor excuse of a winter coat he had on. Katsuki was now visibly shivering in his leather motorcycle jacket as they trekked on. But his husband didn’t make any mention of the pain he was in as he gritted his teeth and pushed forward.

They kept moving, not bothering to stop and clean any blood off of them. They needed to be gone before Chisaki’s goons circled back.

“How many more people do you think they’ll send to try to find us?” Katsuki whispered.

“As many as they have to expend.”

Quietness sliced through them.

Katsuki readjusted his grip on Izuku’s middle section as another loud, angry blast of air hit them.

This far north, the temperature was much colder. It was no longer a light winter but a deep plunge into what felt like the arctic. The forest they were currently weaving through was eerily quiet. As they trudged through the thick snow, their boots crunched against the frozen earth. All the tall pines towered above them, and Izuku noted how their branches sagged, heavy with snow. The trees here casted long shadows under the pale light of the moon, making the canopy they were under seem like a dizzying maze.

Katsuki spoke again, but this time much quieter, “Your tolerance to poison is dropping.”

“Yeah,” Izuku agreed, feeling ashamed. “I haven’t been keeping up the dosing regime since the masquerade. My body is…slowing its metabolism of toxins.”

The ache in his legs felt like a forewarning.

This was now the longest he’s ever had taken to recover from a paralyzer since he was eleven. While it was far above the average for any other regular person, it concerned him. When Jin had sunk the paralyzer into his neck during their final fight, it had taken ten minutes to feel the effects go away. It was slower than his usual three minutes. But if what

the Yakuza men on the train said was true, he was only now starting to feel better after an entire thirty minutes.

Izuku sucked in a breath.

Quietness fell on them again when the howling wind picked up. The chill in the air had settled deep into their bones, but neither of them slowed, and they kept their pace steady despite the exhaustion weighing them down.

Katsuki continued to lead the way, his strong silhouette moved with purpose as he held Izuku up. Soon, Izuku felt his legs return to some semblance of normal and he began to walk on his own. They still stayed huddled close together, bodies trying to fight against the cold.

Then they passed an overlook that was free of trees. There, in the distance was a tiny glimpse of their destination.

Katsuki pointed and sighed out heavily. “That’s it. There’s stupid fucking Mount Rausu.”

Izuku wanted to smile, but his face was hurting from the cold.

They began their hike down, holding hands. Katsuki led the way confidently, and Izuku followed closely behind. His husband’s larger frame shielded him from the cutting winds and Izuku tried to keep their joint hands heated. He breathed on their gloves, puffing in small clouds.

When they reached the bottom, the landscape stretched out before them. It was silent, vast, and untouched. It almost felt like a dream, a world far removed from the chaos they had narrowly escaped. The snow-covered ground gave way to a slight clearing.

As they got closer, their eyes caught a glint of something ahead—a familiar sight. Train tracks.

A crossroad symbol was on a rusted sign beside the tracks. The white paint faded down from the wear of time, making it barely visible against the snow.

In the distance, a cargo freight train rumbled by, its metal wheels screeched against the rails. The train was long and its silhouette cut through the dark, powerful and unyielding. The rhythmic clank of the train grew louder with every passing second. It was here Izuku quickly saw the train was on the tracks that were heading straight for Mount Rausu.

Izuku’s eyes flickered to Katsuki.

Katsuki flickered his eyes to Izuku right back.

They both looked as if they had the same idea.

In tandem, they both took off in a sprint.

This time, for the first time, Katsuki was ahead of him. Izuku pushed his body to keep up as he felt the last bit of paralyzer slip its way out of his legs. He leaned forward into every

powerful step he took and defied the wind that tried to blind him.

“I think we can catch it!” Katsuki shouted over his shoulder, his voice full of determination.

Without a second thought, Izuku pushed forward, his legs burning with each step as he followed Katsuki. The train was moving at a swift rate, but Katsuki was already gaining ground. Izuku’s breath came in quick bursts, his body protesting the speed as they closed in on the cargo train.

Ahead of him, Katsuki reached the tracks first. He didn’t hesitate. With a powerful leap, he grabbed the metal ladder attached to the side of one of the freight cars. His arms flexed, muscles rippling under his motorcycle jacket as he hauled himself up with the ease of someone who had done this a hundred times before.

Izuku’s heart raced high—not solely from the exertion of the run, but from the sight of Katsuki effortlessly pulling himself onto the train, his body strong, sure, and confident.

“Come on!” Katsuki yelled down, his voice full of encouragement, but Izuku felt his chest tighten.

He was still too far away.

Izuku pushed. His legs pumped as hard as they could, but the snow was thick and the ground was uneven. He jumped over several old, rusted metal tracks that nearly tripped him as the sting of the toxin weighed him down. His body ached, his muscles protested, but there was no time to think of that. Not with Katsuki above him, waiting.

The train was moving faster now, but the distance between them was shrinking with every second. However, it was still a leap too far. Izuku’s heart raced with the thought of losing Katsuki, of being left behind, of not being able to keep up.

Right when doubt began to creep into his thoughts, he saw Katsuki’s outstretched hand.

“Izuku!” Katsuki shouted, his voice desperate.

And then he did it.

With a burst of energy, Izuku closed the distance. He launched himself toward the train with everything he had. The cold wind sliced against his skin. The gap between them felt impossible, but in the moment before the world blended around him, he felt Katsuki’s grip on his arm.

Katsuki hoisted him up with a loud guttural yell using all his strength. For a moment, Izuku was weightless, his feet dangled below him. Then Katsuki’s arms were around him, pulling him the rest of the way up onto the train’s metal platform.

They both collapsed onto the cold steel, breathing heavily, their chests rising and falling in unison. Katsuki’s fingers clutched at Izuku’s jacket, as if afraid he might slip away.

“Don’t scare me like that again,” Katsuki chastised.

His hand cupped Izuku's cheek, brushing the cold from his skin with a gentleness that made Izuku's heart flutter.

Izuku nodded, his breath still shaky as he gazed into Katsuki's eyes. "Sorry."

Katsuki smiled then, his eyes softening all the way. The gentle look contrasted the blood of others that was stuck to his skin. He leaned in, brushing his lips lightly against Izuku's forehead.

ᔓᔓᔓ

The train's wheels screeched to a halt, and the sound sliced through the fog of sleep that clung to their bodies. Izuku blinked into the darkness, disoriented for a moment before he realized where they were. The steady rumble of the train had come to an abrupt end, and the quiet that followed was thick with the kind of stillness that only the dead of night could bring.

Izuku sat up, rubbing his eyes as he took in their surroundings. The cold was sharper now and the night air bit into his skin like it had teeth. He could see nothing but the faint outline of trees against the star-streaked sky.

Katsuki then woke up. The bags under his eyes were darker now and the pain from the recent assault was apparent in the way he winced when he moved. He sat up with a loud groan and nursed his stomach that was likely bruised from the gut punch he received.

"I say this in the most un-ironic way, but I feel like I got run over by a fucking freight train," Katsuki grumbled as he rubbed the back of his neck.

Izuku sheepishly smiled at him, appreciating the touch of humor.

Without another word, they hopped down from the freight car, their boots landing softly in the snow that covered the ground. The night was eerily quiet. No sounds of pursuit. No vehicles rumbling in the distance. They were alone in some train track cross roads with only the moon above to witness them.

The Yakuza should've been far gone now. But that only made Izuku want to put more distance between them.

"Let me get some of this blood off me before we go," Katsuki announced.

He reached down and grabbed a lump of snow and slowly threaded it through his hair. He shivered as he did this. The tremor passed from his shoulders to his ankles as he rinsed his hair of the dried blood. The snow fell to the ground, absorbing the old liquid and transforming into a dark red shade. Izuku followed suit, trying his best to wipe off any blood that may bring alarm or attention to them.

They cleaned off the best they could before they decided it was time to get a move on.

Izuku's arms were screaming at him to take a longer breather. But there was no time to linger. They had a long voyage ahead of them, and they were now officially so close. He could see

strong, silent Mount Rausu in the distance. It stood much closer now as a beacon of hope in the dark winter.

They began their long journey into the night.

Katsuki pulled the collar of his leather jacket tight around his neck. The cold was clearly gnawing at him, but it was nothing compared to what they had already been through. Nothing stacked up to the fear of being caught by Tomura and Chisaki.

For the first few hours, they didn't speak much.

Their breaths came in puffs of white mist as they focused on each step. Izuku's legs burned with the effort, but he stayed fueled by the fire in his chest to get to freedom. The thought of making it to Nana with Katsuki was like coal for his own engine that kept him moving along steadily.

They passed through towering pines, the trees looked like silent guardians in the night. The singular sounds were the crunch of their feet in the snow and the occasional rustling of branches above as a cold wind swept through the forest-like area. Izuku tried to focus on the rhythm of his breathing, blocking out the nagging ache in his muscles, the exhaustion threatening to overtake him.

Hours passed in the dead of night.

The stars above flickered coldly, a backdrop to their slow and steady progress.

As the first hints of dawn began to bleed across the horizon, they reached what looked to be a small town. Tiny buildings were haloed against the backdrop of the painted sky with streaks of pale pink and lavender.

Katsuki exhaled loudly at the sight of the sign that read 'Welcome to Shari, Japan!'

Hope swelled inside of him. He grasped Katsuki's hand out of pure joy. Katsuki grasped it right back.

They kept moving, heading straight for the direction that pointed them towards Mount Rausu. With every step Katsuki took there beside him, it felt like they were moving toward something bigger than simply survival.



When they reached the base of the mountain, what felt like eighteen hours had passed. It was night again, and Izuku's internal clock was starting to get turned around. He was mildly lightheaded. They had kept walking without stopping out of sheer fear that the Yakuza were roaming every city in the vicinity to try and trap them.

They came to the opening of the hiking trail and paused.

This was the final ascent. Izuku's heart pounded as he glanced up at the towering peak before them. The summit was still far away, and the climb would undoubtedly get more treacherous from here.

"Did he tell you where to meet on the mountain?" Izuku asked, voice a touch weak.

"No," Katsuki said. He sighed and shook his head. "He said that if I climb, he would be able to see me coming. So we just need to try to get to the top and I'm sure he'll come and find us. He's on the lookout."

Hope dared to spark in Izuku's chest.

They started walking, their boots crunching through the fresh snow. The trail was faint, marked only by the occasional sign of wildlife—prints in the snow or a snapped branch. The mountain air grew thinner the higher they went, but they pressed on, side by side. The climb was steady but unforgiving, the cold ate at them as they wound their way through another dense forest.

Izuku looked up at the mountain, and his breath caught in his throat. The peak loomed ahead, jagged and imposing. But there was something else too. The promise of safety, the knowledge that they were so close to freedom, fueled his every step to the point he caught a second wind. Or was it a third wind? He wasn't sure. But he could feel that Katsuki felt it too.

They pulled down deep inside of them as they began the final leg of the journey, climbing the mountain in silence.

The further up they went, the steeper the path grew. The snow began to deepen, making every step harder to take. But still, they didn't stop. It was hard. It was exhausting. And when they reached the halfway point, the wind howled like a wolf in their faces.

Izuku dared to look over behind him and he saw the most beautiful sight of the ocean. It was shimmering under the pale moonlight and the crescent moon above stood in the sky shyly behind several clouds. With the mountain beneath their feet and the stars decorating the sky above them, Izuku and Katsuki finally allowed themselves a moment to pause.

They looked at each other with the same, silent understanding.

"I never told you where we had to meet Nana," Izuku said.

"Huh. You're right," Katsuki replied. "Where do we have to meet her?"

"The sunny place," Izuku said simply.

Katsuki's eyebrows knitted together in confusion. Then like a bolt of electricity, realization struck across his face and his eyes widened in disbelief. The reference to their failed childhood getaway worked like an arrow piercing through both of their hearts.

"You're joking," Katsuki said.

Izuku grinned until his cheeks hurt. “I’m not. It’s…It’s fitting isn’t it?”

Katsuki stayed suspended in silence. He blinked rapidly, drinking in the sight of Izuku as if he was too good to be true.

“It is,” Katsuki whispered.

They continued on, hand in hand this time. It was here that the final stretch of their hike felt like a dream. The cold air, thin and biting, was nothing compared to the exhilaration of knowing where they were heading. Together.

Maybe it was truly their fate to always end up running away to Okinawa together.

The moon now had fully risen, casting long shadows on the snow-covered ground as they crested the last hill that led to the safe house. The mountain landscape around them stretched wide and serene. The vast silence was intermittently broken by the occasional crunch of snow underfoot.

Suddenly, Izuku felt a laugh bubble up in his chest. It was a laugh as light as air, one that he hadn’t allowed himself to release for what felt like forever.

The tension, the fear, the days of running—it was all nearly behind them now. The thought of the safe house was enough to make everything feel gentler. Izuku turned to Katsuki and felt himself overcome with a new air of joy.

“What are you smiling at, nerd?”

Izuku stopped in his tracks and looked around at the beautiful scenery. He then looked down at the snow and curiously tilted his head when a crazy idea pulled to him. He turned his mischievous eyes on to Katsuki and tilted his head.

“You know, I’ve never had a snowball fight before,” Izuku said slowly.

He bent down and began to gather some snow in his hands. Katsuki frowned at the action and shook his head. He took several steps back and put his hand up.

“Absolutely fucking *not*—”

Before he could finish those words Izuku launched a snowball directly in his face. It collided with the grumpy expression and slid down, leaving behind a wet trail in its wake.

Katsuki slowly lifted up his hands to wipe his face clean in dead silence.

At the fear that he had made a mistake, Izuku nervously awaited his husband’s reaction. And to his delight, when Katsuki pulled his hands back, a wickedly mischievous smirk was spread across his lips.

“Oh, it’s on,” Katsuki said, kicking right into his highly competitive side.

Izuku laughed and began making another snow ball. Katsuki scooped up his own handful of snow and flung it toward Izuku. It hit his shoulder with a satisfying squelch, and Izuku immediately retaliated, launching another snowball that exploded against the side of Katsuki's head.

Katsuki blinked in surprise and a flash of a smile tugged at his lips. He tried to launch another attack, but before he could react, Izuku tossed another snowball at him, hitting him squarely in the chest with a soft, powdery splat. Katsuki yelled out a loud exclamation, the cold shocking him for a moment. Then he laughed. Laughed like he hadn't in so long.

Izuku's heart sung hearing the melodic sound of happiness.

The two of them were both laughing now. Snow flew through the air in a flurry of white as they darted around behind trees on the trail. It felt similar to the past when they would have shoot outs, but now with much, much lower stakes.

They found themselves back in their usual pattern with Izuku running and Katsuki chasing.

Katsuki dodged another snowball and skidded across the ground to gather more snow. His arms flung up to launch a perfect shot at Izuku. It hit him directly in the chest, and Izuku stumbled back, pretending to be knocked off balance.

"Is that all you've got, Deku?" Katsuki taunted. A wicked sparkle danced in his eyes as he scooped up a handful of snow.

"It definitely isn't, slow poke!"

Before Katsuki could respond, Izuku had aimed and thrown it at him with a speed that took him by surprise. It hit him square in the face. Katsuki froze for a moment, blinking as snow trickled down his cheeks. He wiped his eyes with the back of his hand and grinned at Izuku.

"That's it!" Katsuki yelled. He charged forward with renewed energy.

Izuku squealed and ducked out of the way just in time. But Katsuki had already grabbed another handful of snow and had begun to chase after him. Izuku laughed loudly as he sprinted down the hiking trail.

When the path narrowed, Izuku took the lead.

He ran, dodging snowballs right and left. He looked back, stuck his tongue out and teased his husband. He rounded the corner of the mountain trail quickly and prepared to throw his snowball when Katsuki came around the edge. Izuku laughed loudly, cheeks hurting from giggling in the bitter cold—

—Then the sound of a shotgun cocking stopped him cold in his tracks.

Izuku's head snapped forward and the long barrel of a shotgun was placed directly at the center of his chest.

His heart skipped a beat and his laughter died.

The man pointing the gun had one of the meanest glares Izuku had ever seen. His hair and eyes were as black as ink and he was wearing all black winter gear. He was snarling at Izuku with a loose cigarette hanging out his mouth.

Carefully, Izuku put his hands up to surrender.

The man took one step forward and Izuku took one step backwards. They did this three more times until Izuku came right back from where he came.

Katsuki jogged up, oblivious. He was still laughing with a snowball in his hand.

“C’mon, you know running from me never ends well—”

Katsuki choked on his words and dropped his snowball. The dark haired man’s razor sharp gaze skinned him alive.

“Bakugou. Why the *hell* did you bring a snake on my property?”

Chapter End Notes

Let me know what you think below! I know it's been a minute :) I had needed a small break here this last leg because its going to be /a lot/ and I wanted to make sure I didn't accidentally rush the ending. But!! We're almost there at the end!! It's so bittersweet but the light at the end of the tunnel is thereeeee!!! I have the next chapter already written and the one after that is half way done :) so I'm going back to my every other week update schedule :))

Thank you so so much for reading and sticking around this long <3

Chapter 35: Tutti

Chapter Summary

Tutti — (Instrumentation Instructions) Everyone plays together.

Chapter Notes

Hello everyone!! Welcome back :)) thank you so much all the love and warm welcome backs on the last chapter!! Seriously, every one of you made me smile and I'm so happy there's still so many of you here reading after so long with this beast of a fic. LMAO. I hope you enjoy this one!!

Thank you to the LOML Luna for betaing :)

Warnings: Adult Scenes and Themes

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 35 — Tutti

.

.

.

It was rare that Izuku was ever caught off guard.

He could count on one hand the times he's had to surrender at point-blank range to a shotgun —and this was exactly the first.

Katsuki immediately ran forward. His eyes were panicked, and he tried to put himself between Izuku and the gun—but failed. The tall, unmoving man shoved Katsuki back with one arm like a protective father and kept the barrel directly aimed for Izuku's heart.

Katsuki cursed and frantically shook his head.

"Aizawa, hold on a moment. Put the gun down—"

The man did not. He snapped the shotgun upwards to catch under Izuku's chin and pushed up. Both Izuku and Katsuki's breaths hitched high. Izuku held his position, locked in a stare down with Aizawa's cold, hate-filled eyes.

"Bakugou, you better explain what the hell is going on right now or I'm putting a hole through this serpent's throat."

Katsuki grabbed the barrel. "Put the gun down first—"

"—No."

Izuku choked as the end of the barrel jabbed into his Adam's apple.

"He's running from the Yakuza too!" Katsuki blurted out in one breath. Clouds of white from his mouth spilled into the air as he continued to quickly say his explanation. "Chisaki is trying to get his hands on him because we fucked up—we both *severely* fucked up. And he needs protection as much as I do. If they get to him, he's as good as fucking dead."

Aizawa's glare only intensified. "And why should I give a damn?"

"Because he…" Katsuki trailed off. He looked between Izuku and Aizawa, struggling with his words.

Izuku knew to keep his mouth shut, but *god* he wished his husband was more articulate.

"He didn't choose to be a killer—he was trafficked," Katsuki finally settled on.

Silence fell over them just as the snow began to fall. It fell softly in the air, landing gently in all of their hair.

Aizawa cut his eyes to Katsuki.

He was shifting through the words like they were knives, weighing each one, turning them over in his mind. Izuku's pulse hammered in his throat. Then, Aizawa's resolve waivered. Izuku felt it. For a split second, the barrel eased up by a hair.

"You believe that?" Aizawa asked cynically.

"Yes," Katsuki exasperated with all his chest. "It's true. But it's a really long goddamn story. We can all talk about this calmly but I'm telling you he's not going to hurt anyone. I promise."

Aizawa scoffed.

"Are you really that stupid, Bakugou? He's playing on your heart strings. Snakes like him lie to gain the advantage. They have no goddamn honor."

"No, it's true!" Katsuki nearly shouted. "I know it for a fact—"

“—And *I* know for a fact he works for some elusive, lethal underground company where their agents are called Vipers. It’s the same company that killed my best friend over thirty years ago and this particular Viper killed Rin Hiryu.” Aizawa sliced his eyes back to Izuku. “If you think I’d forgive either of those transgressions, you don’t know me at all, Bakugou.”

Izuku could feel beads of sweat form on his forehead despite the cold.

Aizawa knew what Izuku was. He didn’t give a damn about how Izuku was crafted. And given how tightly the information about the Viper Academy was under lock and key, it didn’t surprise him that he only had half of the story.

“But he’s trying to leave!” Katsuki shouted. When Aizawa still didn’t budge, Katsuki began to grow desperate. He groaned, curses spilling into the air as he got closer to the older man. His eyes were wild as he pleaded. “Aizawa, please. He needs our help. He’s who I was talking about at my retirement party when I asked you about Nana and the black folder shit.”

Izuku had never seen Katsuki this way. His husband’s face was contorted with distress and very quickly, Katsuki began to spiral. He begged. He bargained. He looked a split second away from getting on his knees.

But Aizawa remained as unmoving as the mountain they were on.

“Even if all that were true, Bakugou, why are you extending your neck for him? Let him clean up his own goddamn mess.”

“…Because I love him.”

Aizawa whipped his head towards Katsuki.

His eyes widened in shock and the cigarette in his mouth dropped to the ground.

“And I’m also responsible for his mess.” Katsuki shakily exhaled and clasped his hands together like he was praying. “I haven’t been truthful about what’s been going on since Okinawa, Aizawa. There was a lot more to that assignment and I omitted more than half of it from my report. And he…was also with me while I was at the estate for those four months after. Then after that, I put us in a tight bind because I exploded—exactly like you said I would.”

At that, Aizawa stiffened.

His jaw tightened as he asked, “Exactly in what way did you explode?”

“Well. That massacre that was on the news in Tokyo.” Katsuki winced. “The one that was given the name ‘Scarlet Masquerade’…”

“That was *you*?” Aizawa growled angrily.

“Uh, yeah...” Katsuki scratched behind his head.

“*Goddamnit*, Bakugou—”

Aizawa cursed under his breath and instantly snatched the shotgun off Izuku.

He whirled around like he couldn't believe what he was hearing and pinched the bridge of his nose. Izuku watched as he closed his eyes and took in a deep inhale. Then Aizawa muttered under his breath a few times, too low for Izuku to really catch what he said. All he could hear was 'children' and 'the death of me'.

When Aizawa turned back around, he was red in the face like Katsuki worked his very last nerve.

"You're going to explain everything—*in vivid goddamn detail*—when we get inside," Aizawa lectured sternly. He pointed to Izuku with the gun again. "Tie him up. I'll decide after I hear whatever story you have if he's going to be executed here and now or not."

Katsuki was ready to protest.

However, Izuku turned around and obediently placed his hands behind his back.

He waited for Katsuki to do what he was told. His husband roughly exhaled and then shuffled through his bag. He took out red rope that was buried at the bottom and uncoiled it. Izuku didn't say a word as his husband tied his arms and wrists, double knotting, until Aizawa seemed to be satisfied.

"Sorry," Katsuki murmured in his ear as he tightened the last knot. "It'll be okay. He'll understand once we explain everything to him."

Izuku nodded, wordlessly. He tried to think of something to keep him calm, but he came up short. This whole situation was like walking across a bridge that had dynamite taped underneath, unknowing if it could explode at any moment.

Aizawa turned on his feet.

"Follow me," he grumbled.

Katsuki gently grabbed Izuku by his elbow and led him along. The wind pushed against their backs as they quietly followed Aizawa further up the mountain. As they traveled deeper into the jagged trail, it ended not too far off from where they had their standoff.

They were now trudging through nearly knee deep snow, until they came to a wall of tall, intimidating trees. The thick bases stood there like guardians, keeping dutifully strong and watching over the mountain. Their trunks were pushed together with no sliver of room to get by and their evergreen branches stretched towards the night sky.

One particular tree in the center was full of evergreen vines. Its bark was barely noticeable underneath all the tiny leaves that wrapped around it, dangling down.

To a passer by, it probably seemed like nothing. But to Izuku, it stood out a touch from the rest.

His gut instinct was confirmed when Aizawa stepped forward and pushed aside the vines. Underneath, a small wooden door was exposed. Aizawa opened it easily to reveal a tunnel through the mountain. They walked in, ducking underneath the vines as they entered the pitch black passageway. The cave here was narrow, and the winds blasted through at higher speeds. Izuku squinted as they headed straight for the light on the other side.

When they finally breached the exit, Izuku had to stop himself from gaping.

Nestled into the side of the mountain was a large fortress of a cabin. It was completely isolated, occupying the entire ledge that jutted from the rock.

Its timbers were dark with age and weathered by the breath of countless winters. Moss clung to the stone foundation like an old memory, and the roof was thick with a quilt of snow that glowed under the silver gaze of the night sky. In contrast, a soft golden light spilled from the windows. It flickered like candle light through frosted glass, making it appear as if the cabin itself had a heartbeat.

All around the cabin, the forest stood tall.

Birch trees, long and pale, were gathered like silent sentinels with their branches etched with ice and starlight. Izuku noted the wind moved gentler here, like a lullaby threading through their ears. He inhaled and the scent of cedar and firewood filled his lungs.

But the background was the most beautiful, breathtaking view Izuku had ever seen.

It was a perfect look across the country at such heights. He could see all the hills, the towns, and the ocean off to the side. The moon above shone down on the snow and the clouds hovered above, watching.

Aizawa turned to them.

“Welcome to winter paradise.”

ᔓᔓᔓ

The warmth of the cabin felt like a long awaited hug. Both him and Katsuki melted into it when the radiance of the fireplace filled their senses and graced their chilled bodies.

Aizawa led them out the doorway, and they entered into a large, spacious living room.

The first thing that caught Izuku’s eyes was the interior. The cabin had a high ceiling, and one entire side of the living room wall was a large window. It gave a perfect look out to the view across the country and on the other side was a balcony. The wooden walls were full of old photographs that had seen years, but held no dust. And all around were shelves carved from driftwood, gently curved into the walls. They were lined with leather-bound books and curious trinkets.

And in the middle of the living room sat a heavy wooden table. The surface was scarred and etched with wear from the years. It sat across from the roaring fireplace on top of a large fur

rug.

But sitting around on the long couches in front of that table were five strangers.

Like clockwork, all eyes turned towards them.

There was a woman with pretty brown skin and platinum blonde hair. She was the first to react. She made a bewildered face and stared at him like some mythical creature that had sprouted wings and jumped off the page of a story book.

The next was a short blond that had a stripe of black in his hair shaped like an electric bolt. He spluttered a loud, “huh?!” when Izuku came into the light. After him, a guy with the same black hair and eyes as Aizawa tilted his head. His mouth dropped and he blinked like he was unsure if he was hallucinating.

Then finally, the last two strangers in the room cursed under their breaths.

Izuku instantly recognized those two. They were Katsuki’s blond and purple haired coworkers that he had the displeasure of meeting in Biei. The men exchanged knowing glances and the blond one in particular dropped his head. He exhaustedly muttered ‘I fucking knew it’ quietly.

“Um. What is this?” The woman with blonde hair asked slowly. She sat up right, frowned, and eyed Izuku. “I thought this was a fix-Katsuki’s-fuck-up-assignment? Isn’t this the guy who you issued a search and kill for? The one who killed Hiryu?”

“It is,” Aizawa grumbled. “I caught these two outside—having a snowball fight.”

Izuku and Katsuki grimaced when perplexed glares were tossed their way.

“Sero, get me a glass of whiskey,” Aizawa ordered.

The young man who shared his features jumped at the command. He looked at Izuku once, entirely taken back, and rushed into the kitchen. When he came back he handed Aizawa a glass cup that was filled to the brim.

Aizawa gulped it all down at once.

“You two, sit right there.” Aizawa pointed to the spot in front of the fireplace. “And don’t move a single inch.”

Izuku and Katsuki jumped to follow orders. They sat down on the plush, fur rug with their back to the fireplace. Izuku sat on his hunches while Katsuki went criss-cross.

Katsuki still hadn’t let go of his elbow, and his grip switched to protective. All the prying eyes were cautiously studying them. They scanned their bruises, cuts, and the flakes of dried blood that clung to them both. Given how everyone was gawking, they must’ve looked as if they traveled through hell and back.

Aizawa sat down in the middle of the couch between everyone. He raised an eyebrow when he could see Izuku cautiously eye all the people, a bit like a scared puppy.

“This is Miruko,” he pointed to the blonde woman on his left. “And this is Denki, my nephew Sero, and Shinsou.” His hand loosely gestured to the canary blond, the young man who shared his traits, and the stoic purple hair guy in the corner. “And finally, this is Monoma.” He flicked his wrist to the blond with blue eyes.

Then without a moment’s hesitation, he leveled his shotgun at Izuku. He locked eyes with Katsuki, glare burning.

“Start talking.”



Well.

This wasn’t quite the welcome Izuku anticipated, but truthfully, what was he expecting? A cup of hot cocoa awaiting him with a blanket? He should have known better that going to a rival company for help would be dicey.

Izuku let Katsuki take the reins after they exchanged a glance steeped in hesitation. Neither of them knew quite how to begin, but Katsuki cleared his throat and started from the origin of it all—Okinawa.

He spoke with a careful cadence, unraveling the story thread by thread. He described their initial meeting, the tense flicker of recognition that almost detonated the mission before it even started. Next, he spoke of their charade of a marriage, hastily fabricated and surprisingly convincing. Katsuki walked everyone through each day like he was navigating a minefield.

But Izuku noticed a subtle omission.

Katsuki completely skipped over the night they got obliterated on cheap alcohol and woke up accidentally married.

He glanced at his husband with subtle confusion, but said nothing.

Katsuki had his reasons, Izuku was sure.

Then the tale shifted, the stage changed—it was now Tokyo. Katsuki painted his year there in hues of grit and quiet devastation. He revealed how that one solemn year tangled their lives together, and stuck with him in dreams until this day.

“He took care of me every day for a year when my mother left me alone,” Katsuki confessed quietly. His head was down and his grip on Izuku’s arm tightened. “When we figured out that we were each other’s lost best friend…a change happened.”

It was then Izuku noticed it—the imperceptible thaw in Aizawa’s stern demeanor.

His scowl faltered. Dark eyes now assessed Izuku not with judgment, but with curiosity.

Katsuki continued on and gave a full, honest report on how they killed Peter Moore. At all the new details, Aizawa dropped his head and shook it.

Katsuki ignored this and pushed on, continuing to paint the picture of the bloodshed he and Izuku spilled that night. He easily segued into Izuku hurting his ankle in the woods, and needing to be taken care of. He fondly recalled how that led them to spending their time in Biei together for four months. He set the scene of those intimate days they shared—how they reconnected through small moments and laughter that felt genuine, almost sacred.

He confessed they were the best months of his life.

Then came the descent: Izuku needing to return to The Viper Academy, the red folder, and how it was revealed that Izuku was the assassin hired to kill his mother.

The mood in the room snapped taut. All gazes sharpened into spears aimed at Izuku.

With silent understanding, Izuku took over.

He tried to start at the beginning—his beginning. He spoke of his upbringing in Tokyo's shadows, where empathy was not taught but extracted. Under the cold weight of so many suspicious eyes, his instincts begged him to shut down, to slip into silence. But then Katsuki's hand came to rest on his shoulder. It was a grounding warmth that steadied his trembling breath.

Through all his tremors, he spoke of it. The training. The poisoning. How they were groomed to kill and feel nothing. When he detailed the basement and The Cull, he could see several of the strangers in front of him churn with sickness. A few in the room turned pale, nausea rising at the monstrous truth.

But worst of all, when Izuku described what happened with Hiryu, he could see pity spill into the air.

Then Izuku got to what he always knew to be the night of 'The Incident'.

It was painful, retelling it again.

His throat caught around the words like they were barbed wire. Guilt slithered through him, quiet and suffocating. His shame was a dusk-fallen shadow that grew longer and longer as he continued. It clung to him, whispering cruel reminders of everything he could never undo. Izuku couldn't stop the way he cried through it. He horribly remembered the way Mitsuki's body fell to the ground.

"That night is my biggest regret," Izuku rasped, tears clinging to his lashes. "I wish I never took the shot."

A long pause was taken here.

Izuku held his head down and let shame gnaw at him.

Katsuki was stiff and quiet.

No one spoke, as if they all took a moment of silence for the tragedy of it all.

Eventually, Izuku inhaled his grief and pushed forward. He brought up Tomura here, and truly went into detail about how terrifying he was. He painted the vision that Tomura is what a perfect Viper would be considered. He was cold, brilliant, and void of all emotions but bloodlust. His Big Brother was a true apex predator draped in the skin of a man.

When he told the room how Tomura beheaded their previous handler and rose to power, he saw fear dance across a couple faces.

Then came Chisaki.

Izuku talked about the man's growing obsession with him. Bile tickled the back of his throat as he spoke of the unsettling way his virginity had been bought like it was a rare emerald for Chisaki's collection. After that, the air shifted. Disgust, horror, and rage all coalesced in the eyes trained on him. He talked about how Tomura was desperately trying to melt the Vipers into the Yakuza in order to gain power—and Izuku was the bridge all his plans hinged on.

There was a pause before Izuku got to Okinawa.

Izuku hesitated, knowing Katsuki had left a major truth unsaid. So he too chose silence on the matter of their drunken marriage.

He gave his side of things for Okinawa and Biei, which pretty much mirrored Katsuki's. Then he explained how he found out he was Mitsuki's killer the night of Katsuki's retirement party. He could still feel Tomura's fury from that night, it wound around him like a noose and choked him.

Then Izuku explained how he had left a letter—not a red folder.

It was painful, how he had to recall the complicated relationship between him and his deceased sister, Himiko. Her motive for switching the two items was clear: she wanted Izuku dead, and she wanted Katsuki to do it. She wanted to make him hurt in the same way he had hurt her all those years ago.

Then he got to the night of the Masquerade.

Izuku glanced at Katsuki, and together they unraveled the chaos.

Their narratives clashed and danced, each from a different vantage. And in that dissonance, Himiko's genius became clear. She always had a way of being simple, wicked and utterly devastating.

It didn't go unnoticed to Izuku how Aizawa's temper rose again. But this time, it wasn't directed at him. He was glaring into Katsuki deeper and deeper with every new soul that Katsuki recounted collecting.

Then Izuku awkwardly put in the detail that five of those people were directly related to Chisaki Kai.

The reaction was immediate. Excruciating groans filled the room.

“Bakugou, you absolute *dumbass*,” Monoma hissed through clenched teeth.

Izuku didn’t argue. He then detailed exactly how incensed Chisaki had become.

He described the fury that rivaled a thousand wars and how the man was fit to slaughter everyone he saw. Hesitantly, Izuku vaguely recalled that Chisaki figured out Katsuki was the killer at the Masquerade. Then he fully demanded a life for a life from the Vipers to settle the blood score and threw Izuku into a cell until further notice.

Izuku had carefully skipped over the marriage certificate reveal to follow suit with Katsuki’s omission.

But he saw it. Some eyes in the room squinted, like they could feel a piece of the puzzle was missing.

Before questions could be fired, Izuku barreled ahead to talk about his own massacre that occurred that same night. He told everyone how his brother Tomura brutally chose the five children in their care to be executed.

Everyone was taken aback, but Izuku continued his story. He detailed his escape, cutting down as many Vipers as possible and taking the children and fleeing to Nana for safety.

Izuku then caught their story up with Katsuki tracking him down.

It was here that his husband stepped in again, a touch nervous.

He picked up the thread, telling everyone how they worked it out and eventually got on the same page. They were beginning to resolve the gaping, Mitsuki shaped hole between them but they really only had so much time. In their chaotic tale, dark shadows still churned behind them. The Vipers and Yakuza were now united, hunting them like wolves.

And now, here they were: on the run.

“Nana said she could help us disappear to a place that they can’t reach us,” Izuku explained with finality, his voice shaky. “If we could make it to her in Okinawa in five and a half weeks’ time, we’ll be safe.”

Everyone was staring at them with different expressions.

Aizawa was working his jaw in frustration, but sympathy was apparent in his eyes. Miruko was similar, but slightly more trusting. Sero gave a low, impressed whistle at all of the mess and Monoma’s lips were pressed into a thin line. He thoughtfully strummed his fingers on his thighs. Shinsou was still fully guarded. His eyes were like icicles, sharp and distrusting as he regarded Izuku.

Out of everyone, Izuku noted that Shinsou was the one of the group that was not moved at all by his story.

Everyone else had given slightly at something. Whether it was the trafficking, The Cull, Tomura, or even the arrangement with Chisaki. Everyone in front of him buckled slightly under the weight of the ugliness he had endured—except Shinsou.

Aizawa shifted tiredly and said, “This has got to be the second biggest mess I’ve ever heard in all my years.” He shook his head and his sunken eyes studied Izuku. “If what you’re saying is true, then you really were trafficked at a young age…weren’t you?”

Izuku nodded, feeling ashamed for some reason. “I was.”

“I see.” Aizawa rubbed his chin as he mulled over a thought.

“I have one question,” Denki suddenly interjected with his finger up. All eyes turned to him and he made a pained, conflicted face. “No offense but there’s a part that kind of doesn’t—make sense to me? Why would Chisaki demand blood from the Vipers for *Katsuki’s* massacre? And why would they throw *you* in a cage because of it?”

And there was the million dollar question.

Izuku could feel the moment approaching. It hung in the air like the scent of lightning before a storm. And when Katsuki exhaled like a man about to walk into a firing squad, Izuku knew.

He was going to say it.

“There’s actually, uh, one more, rather large, detail.” Katsuki turned his gaze slowly back to everyone. “I left it out because I didn’t want to distract from the more pressing parts, but… the reason Izuku got punished is because Chisaki found a very damning public record that ties us together.”

Katsuki cleared his throat.

“In Okinawa, we got married.”

His voice didn’t crack. Didn’t stutter. It was said as bluntly as if he’d just announced the weather. But it might as well have been like dropping a bomb.

“Married?!” Denki’s voice splintered like a guitar string breaking. “Like—legally?”

“No,” Katsuki snapped sarcastically, “Spiritually. Yes, idiot. *Legally*.”

The room broke out into chaos. A cacophony of exclamations, shouts and questions clashed together like an out of tune band trying to all play their own song.

Sero blinked rapidly. “Holy shit—”

“—I told you to *kill* him not fucking *marry* him, Bakugou,” Aizawa hissed, ready to shove his foot down Katsuki’s throat.

Miruko gasped a loud ‘oh my god’ and plopped backwards on the couch. Shinsou threw his hand over his face while Monoma turned away. It was obvious those two could no longer witness this train wreck. Aizawa then threw his head back as if this revelation added ten years to his life expectancy—in reverse.

“You married him?” Shinsou jeered, jabbing a finger in Izuku’s direction like he was a stain. “The guy you’ve been trying to kill for years? Why the hell would you do that?”

“Technically, it was accidental,” Izuku offered, sheepishly. “We were black out drunk.”

That didn’t help. In fact, it made it worse.

“So you’re telling me,” Miruko stammered slowly, “That two very well trained killers for hire, got wasted at some cheesy, gimmicky vacation spot and accidentally tied the knot? And you didn’t immediately find a way to get it nullified in the whole *four* months you spent together afterwards?”

“I never said we were perfect,” Katsuki muttered begrudgingly.

“So why not get divorced?” Miruko questioned.

“Isn’t it obvious?” Aizawa interjected. He pulled his head to the side and stared at the two husbands. “They don’t want to. It’s written across their faces—these two are lovesick.”

Everyone else grew quiet like that was impossible.

Now they were all surveying Izuku and Katsuki closely, like they were two books on a shelf with wide open pages for the world to see. Izuku could feel each and every gaze pluck him apart. They were searching his body language, trying to find out if this was some dubious trap to bring Katsuki down into the grave—but it wasn’t.

All there was to be found was the infinite love in Izuku’s heart for Katsuki.

“Holy shit,” Sero repeated again, much more taken aback. “Bakugou, you’re in *love*? How is that even possible?!”

Denki was equally perplexed. “You quite literally have shouted ‘fuck romance’ in public several times?”

“Not to mention berated couples who did PDA in front of him,” Monoma muttered.

Katsuki shrugged half heartedly. “Feelings change.”

“But he killed your *mom*, Bakugou,” Shinsou emphasized with disgust. “Surely you’re not going to simply glide over that.”

“We didn’t glide over it,” Katsuki bit back. He scowled defensively and bore his threatening glare into Shinsou. “Shit is more complicated than that and I’m not defending my goddamn life choices about him to you two again.”

Aizawa paused.

“Again?” He questioned. He turned to Monoma and Shinsou carefully. “What does he mean by *again*?”

Both Monoma and Shinsou grew quiet. They awkwardly shifted like kids being caught somewhere they weren’t supposed to be.

Aizawa’s eyes narrowed.

“Wait. You two *knew*,” he seethed and Miruko’s mouth dropped further in shock. “When I sent you up to Biei to drag this knuckle head back, you saw them there together, didn’t you? And you didn’t think to say a *word* about it?”

“Bakugou asked us not to,” Monoma defended. He threw his hands up and shook his head. “Like you said, they seem hopelessly in love or whatever. I felt bad and he practically groveled on the ground for us not to say a word.”

“More like he threatened us with a gun,” Shinsou muttered.

That wasn’t *at all* how Izuku remembered it, but sure.

Aizawa lifted up his finger, ready to give a scathing lecture. But then he caught himself mid-breath. He shook his head and gestured ‘absolutely not’ with his hands before turning his attention to the matter at hand.

He worked his jaw, clearly wavering between two thoughts as he glanced between the young lovers in front of him. Like a pendulum, his eyes swung back and forth between red and green.

He was still deciding what to do.

Desperation crawled its way out of Izuku’s throat when his grasp on hope began to slip.

“Please,” Izuku begged. He screwed his eyes shut and dropped his head low. “I know it’s wrong to ask for your help. It goes against everything in my being to do this, b-but I need your help—we need your help. Katsuki is the one they want dead and I don’t want him to be hurt. I couldn’t live with myself knowing that he’s in harm’s way because he got involved in my life. If you want something for your time, I can give you all the money I have on my person. I don’t have much, but I can give you everything I have if it means he’ll be safe.”

Izuku bowed low to the ground. He touched his forehead to the rug and pleaded with all he had.

“I know what type of life I’ve lived,” Izuku uttered mournfully. “I’ll never fully outrun it. Forced or not, I still killed hundreds, if not thousands. But if I have any chance to do something right—anything at all—I want it to be making it up to Katsuki. I want to keep Katsuki safe and watch out for him for as long as I live. I-I want to earn my life.”

Everyone grew quiet.

Silence swallowed them, and Izuku heard one person stand up from the couch.

He dared to look up. It was Miruko.

She was gazing down at him with mixed emotions. “For someone who killed their husband’s mother, you sure make it sound so poetic.”

“I only want to make sure Katsuki is taken care of,” Izuku confessed, voice breaking a little on the words. “That’s all I’ve ever wanted.”

The room was quiet again. But now it wasn’t sharp—it was thoughtful.

Miruko dusted her white pants slightly and he could see a conclusion settle on her face. She was the first of the group to break from formation and walked around the table. She crouched in front of Izuku, studying him like a soldier assessing a battlefield.

She looked into his eyes, and Izuku couldn’t help but notice they were kind.

“You’re scared, aren’t you?” She asked sadly.

“I’m always scared,” Izuku whispered. “But I’ve learned to push through it.”

That got her.

She stood, turning to Aizawa. “Well?”

Aizawa had watched the entire exchange in silence, jaw set. Finally, he stood up. He didn’t say a word, simply gave a single, stern glance towards Katsuki. He placed the gun down on the table with a loud clunk and walked behind Izuku. He pulled out a knife and squatted down. With jagged motions from his blade, he began to cut Izuku free from his restraints.

The ropes fell away, and both Izuku and Katsuki let out twin breaths in total relief. It took all Izuku had to not embrace Katsuki then and there. He was beyond relieved to have survived such an intense interrogation.

Aizawa walked in front of him and tilted his head. “So what’s your name?”

“My name is Izuku,” he whispered.

Aizawa sighed from the depths of his spirits.

ɯɯɯ

Aizawa dismissed them all with the laziest flick of his wrist, like even lifting his hand was a burden too heavy to bear.

But, without missing a beat, the colorful group followed his command. Their exit wasn’t dramatic. There were no complaints, no shouting or objecting. It was a quiet unraveling that communicated that everyone was still digesting what they heard.

On the way out, Miruko and Denki spared Izuku kind, pity filled smiles that held some semblance of understanding.

On the other hand, Monoma and Sero didn't look at him directly. They made eye contact with Katsuki, and shared intense looks of apprehension. Only Monoma tossed one, unsure backwards glance Izuku's way before leaving.

Then finally, the last person to leave was Shinsou.

There was something different about the way he viewed Izuku. The disgust was palpable. It dripped off him like rolling beads of rain from a window, each gathering into a large puddle of visible distrust. When Shinsou rolled his eyes, Izuku knew then there would likely be no changing this guy's mind about him. He viewed Izuku as the snake he was meant to be, and nothing more.

Everyone was swallowed up by the dimly lit halls one by one. When no one's footsteps could be heard, that left him, Katsuki and Aizawa.

Izuku couldn't tell what the older man was thinking. His dark gaze was picking them both apart as he mulled over some unknown thought. As he did this, the bags under his eyes could've been mistaken for actually carrying rocks with how large, and heavy they were.

"Follow me," Aizawa commanded. "I guess it's time to give you a tour around where you'll be staying—and neither of you touch shit in my house before you shower. You both stink."

Izuku and Katsuki exchanged soft, gentle smiles. Warmth spread from limb to limb as excitement took the wheel.

They did it. They *finally* made it to safety in one piece. It took everything Izuku had to contain his relief. They both stood up and took their backpacks in tow as the wind rattled the old cabin.

Quietly, the pair of husbands allowed Aizawa to take them up and down the house.

He showed them every room and Izuku was surprised at how alive it felt.

Door by door, the house unfolded like pages of a well loved storybook. Each chapter was a room that was steeped in its own hues and memories. The reading room welcomed them first. It was anchored by a vintage blue couch whose fabric had softened from the years of companionship. It slouched slightly in the middle, as though cradling the ghosts of the past who were still curled up with their books.

Then came the drawing room. It was robed in velvety purples that hugged the walls like dusk does before nightfall. The large armchairs were arranged in a circle, close enough to trade secrets or laughter over steaming mugs. To Izuku, it felt like a room made for confessions, where conversations could float easily in the space between flickering candlelight and the clink of ceramic.

Next came the sunroom and the balcony—each a love letter to time. Small nicks were in the wood, faded spots in the curtains, and the windowsill was etched with the quiet chaos of years lived fully. These weren't blemishes, but rather the fingerprints of life—proof that joy, mess, and memory had danced freely through these halls.

As Aizawa guided them back toward the living quarters, he paused at a modest door tucked into the back. Beyond it was another porch much like the front. However, this porch was more intimate. It slung to the side of the mountain like a secret.

On this side of the cabin, the air was crisper and it made Izuku curiously lean into the frosted window. Below, he saw a faint trail that dipped its way into the wilderness. It was covered in snow, but still showed signs of recent use.

Aizawa lightly tapped the glass and pointed.

"Do you see that line in the back?" He asked. "It's faint right now because it's dark, but squint the best you can."

Izuku got closer to the cold glass and did what Aizawa said. He was rewarded with the very subtle visual of a grey line cutting across the horizon. It sloped downwards, and was barely visible to the eye from this distance.

Katsuki tilted his head. "What is that?"

"That's an emergency path down the mountain," Aizawa informed them. "It's an abandoned ski lift and it'll drop you off at the outskirts of the town below. I repurposed it once I bought this land up here, and now it's basically my own personal fire escape."

Izuku nodded, approving of the smart getaway system.

"If anything happens…" Aizawa warned, slightly on edge. He turned and looked each of them carefully in the eye. "Make sure to take this and get out immediately. Don't be sitting ducks stuck up here."

Katsuki's expression hardened into a seriousness and so did Izuku's. They both took one more good look at the ski lift before following Aizawa back into the living quarters section. As they strolled down the hall, Izuku noted all the different bedrooms. Soft, yellow light spilled out from underneath some of the doors like little sun rays while others were fully dark.

Katsuki gave a low whistle, half in awe.

"Is this like, all yours?" he asked. He twirled a lazy finger in the air, as if gesturing to the entire mountain itself.

"Yes, Bakugou. It is all mine," Aizawa tiredly replied. He looked over his shoulder with an expression as dry as dust. "I use it when I want to be migraine free for a while. But as you can see…" He gestured vaguely toward the two of them. "It doesn't always work."

Katsuki clicked his tongue and rolled his eyes. “But what made you buy it all the way up here?”

“Simple. I hate people.”

Short and to the point. Izuku could respect it.

“You’re so damn dramatic, old man.”

They stopped at a door nestled snugly between the others, as if it had quietly claimed its place in the heart of the hallway.

Aizawa pushed it open with a gentle creak and revealed a room that felt like a quiet retreat.

A single queen-sized bed rested against the far wall, cradled in a warm wooden frame that looked like it had been carved from the trees in the forest. The blue comforter on top was slightly rumpled and at the center of the room there was a large, charming rug. It had threads woven together to make an artistic image of a small deer standing peacefully among a ring of wildflowers. It was such an unexpectedly tender touch that made the space feel alive, like a hidden glade in barren woods.

To add to it, next to the bed, two modest windows let in soft moon light while a sturdy desk sat under one of them. Then off in the corner, a washroom was tucked away so neatly it almost disappeared into the walls.

But what caught Izuku’s eye the most were the several piles of clothes, towels, and toiletries awaiting on top of the comforter.

“I admittedly only picked up a few clothes that were in Katsuki’s size,” Aizawa explained apologetically. “I wasn’t aware he was going to be bringing company. I’ll make sure to head down into town tomorrow and pick you up some fresh clothes that are your size, Izuku.”

Izuku bowed politely. “Thank you.”

“Don’t mention it.”

It was here that Izuku saw what he always heard in Katsuki’s stories. Aizawa’s nonchalant attitude was thick, but lying underneath was his sincere, genuine care for people. It was soft like delicate flowers and made Izuku feel protected.

“Now, go ahead and get a good night’s rest you two,” Aizawa murmured. “We’ll talk more in depth in the morning.”

ɯɯɯ

Showering felt like heaven poured straight from the pipes.

Izuku let out a low groan as his muscles finally began to unwind under the sweltering heat. He turned the pressure as high as the rickety shower would allow. The steaming water

pounded against his sore limbs, scrubbing away days of sweat, dirt, and dried blood of the various Yakuza and Vipers. He dropped his head against the tile wall, letting the water run in rivulets down his back.

When he finally stepped out, the washroom billowed with a thick cloud of steam that followed him like a fog. He padded into the room slowly, toweling off, skin still flushed and pink from the heat.

Waiting for him, already tucked into bed, was Katsuki.

His husband was leaning against the wooden headboard, lids heavy and lashes low. But his mouth curled into that quiet, private smile he reserved for Izuku and Izuku alone.

Izuku smiled back, heart warm.

He threw on the oversized clothes Aizawa had left folded at the foot of the bed. The black shirt swallowed him whole, slipping right off one shoulder. Katsuki let out a low laugh. It was soft and unguarded. Izuku hadn't heard that particular laughter from Katsuki since Biei.

"You look like a damn ghost in that thing," Katsuki snickered.

Izuku huffed, trying to glare but failed miserably. "C'mon. It's not that big."

"It's swallowing you whole," Katsuki deadpanned. "If you vanish in the middle of the night, I'm checking the laundry pile first."

"Shut up," Izuku said half-heartedly, still laughing.

While still chuckling, he dove into bed beside his husband. The moment his body hit the mattress, it was like every vertebra in his spine finally gave up the fight. He sank deeper, bone by bone, exhaling a sigh that deflated his entire soul.

He rolled into Katsuki's warmth, wrapping himself in strong arms that pulled him in without hesitation. Their limbs tangled until they fit together like two halves of the same soul.

Izuku glanced at the wooden Grandfather clock in the corner. It was an impressive 03:02 a.m.

Katsuki lovingly rested his head on Izuku's. His lips caressed the damp curls at Izuku's temple. And then his thumb lazily stroked at Izuku's waist beneath the borrowed shirt.

"We're almost there," Katsuki whispered.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku could barely pry his eyes open.

His body felt like it had been filled with lead. Every limb was either heavy, aching, or worn down to the bone. His brain protested movement, as if even thinking about shifting was too much. A low groan rumbled from his throat as he rolled onto his side, muscles tensing

automatically when a sharp throb pulsed from his still-healing stab, cut, and gunshot wounds.

Even with a half awake mind, Izuku could process the adrenaline that had carried him through the last stretch was long gone.

He weakly blinked his eyes open when he saw a bundle of blond hair.

His husband stood beside the bed, quiet and still. His back was illuminated in the soft light that was filtering through the curtained windows. He was dressed in a cozy black sweater and matching sweatpants.

Overall, Katsuki looked like he had been up for a while. His sharp eyes were watchful even in the quiet. A mug of coffee steamed in his hand, the scent grounding and rich in the air.

“Kacchan?” Izuku’s voice was scratchy, still wrapped in sleep. He tried to push himself up, but his body protested. Fresh pain shot through his side and down to his ankles. He winced. “Is it time to get up?”

Soft lips kissed his forehead.

“Don’t worry. Keep resting, Izuku.”

The words wrapped around him with the same care as Katsuki’s arms, even if he wasn’t being held yet. Izuku gave up the fight without another thought. He let his head drop back onto the pillow and a long breath spilled from his lungs.

“M’kay,” Izuku whispered quietly, eyes fluttering shut once more.

Katsuki crouched beside the bed. Calloused fingers threaded through Izuku’s curls, slow and gentle. Izuku leaned into the touch, breathing deep, letting himself be taken care of in the quiet peace.

ɯɯɯ

When Izuku woke up fully, it was somehow pitch black outside. At first, he assumed that he only slept a couple hours. But when he checked the GrandFather clock in the room, he was surprised to see it was 02:21 a.m—which meant an entire day had gone by.

He lurched forward in shock.

“Well. Good morning sleeping beauty,” Katsuki’s voice chimed in beside him, fully awake. “Or should I say good night? Not quite sure how that would work.”

Izuku whipped around to look at his husband, completely startled. Katsuki was shirtless, perched lazily upright against the headboard with a random book open in his hands. He gave Izuku a completely serene smile.

“W-Was I really out the whole day?” Izuku asked.

“Yeah, I had no clue you could knock out like that,” Katsuki replied. He closed the book he was reading and turned to Izuku. “I think you unlocked a whole new volume in your snoring —the whole damn cabin heard.”

Izuku groaned. He pushed the heels of his palms into his eyes and shook his head.

“This is so embarrassing. I-I’ve never slept that long before—everyone was probably waiting on me to wake up.”

“Hey. Don’t sweat it,” Katsuki comforted. He reached out a hand to caressed Izuku’s shoulder. “There’s a first time for everything and this is understandable. No one cared that you slept in.”

Izuku did his best to shove down his shame. “How long have you been awake, Kacchan?”

“I slept pretty long as well,” Katsuki confessed. “I got up sometime around the afternoon and then got back into bed later and slept my ass off too. But now I can’t get back to sleep. I decided to rummage through some of the old man’s books hoping they were boring enough to put me back to sleep, but surprisingly everything has been pretty intriguing. He’s got weirdly good taste.”

Izuku chuckled and looked down at the book in Katsuki’s hand.

It was titled, ‘Inferno’ and the author was Dan Brown. Izuku held back a small snicker. He never would have thought his husband would take a liking to Dan Brown.

“Are you going to go back to sleep?” Izuku asked.

Katsuki shook his head. “I don’t think so—or at least not for a while. I’m wide awake. I kind of want to keep reading this book.” He held it up and smiled innocently. “This shit is pretty good.”

“Ha, okay,” Izuku mused. He scooted against the headboard and allowed his body to relax. “You can keep reading. I won’t bother you.”

At that, Katsuki gave him a tender glance. Then he turned his attention back to the book.

A familiar silence fell upon them. It fell like the gentle snow outside, trickling in entirely unhurried. Izuku hugged his legs to his chest as he continued to look at the night sky.

The moon was shining brightly, offering pale light so beautiful it felt like it was made of silver. Izuku stared at the elegant creature in the sky. It felt closer up here at this altitude. Big, bright, and lovely.

Izuku turned. He looked at Katsuki and found himself doing what he loved best: admiring him.

He appreciated everything he could drink in. The soft way Katsuki’s hair fell against his angular face. The sharp edge of his eyes that was only rivaled by his blade. The shade of his skin that felt more ethereal under the moonlight.

Katsuki truly was beautiful—and it frightened Izuku how much he loved him.

“You need to stop staring at me like that,” Katsuki chastised without looking up from the book.

Izuku tilted his head. “Like what?”

“As if I’m going to disappear.”

“Sorry,” he whispered. “I’m still grasping that this is all real. I can’t help but feel like you might slip away.”

“Izuku. I’m not going anywhere, you got that?”

“I got it,” Izuku replied, just below a murmur.

But there wasn’t enough resolve in his words for Katsuki, he supposed. Because within the next second, his husband closed his book and turned towards him.

He inched close, and Izuku held his breath.

He searched Katsuki’s eyes, lost in the blaze of hypnotizing red that sucked him in.

They shared a quiet, private look. It was so intimate that Izuku felt as if Katsuki had slipped directly into his thoughts. Their breaths synced, quickening together. Then, slowly, their eyes dilated in unison as they leaned toward each other, drawn like magnets.

“I’ll only leave your side in death,” Katsuki whispered, voice like velvet and steel. “And even then, I’ll claw my way back to you.”

They closed the distance, instantly.

Heat soaked into Izuku’s body like earth drinking sunlight. His heart fluttered and his head was as light as a cloud. Soft tongues touched. Shy bites sunk into his lips. Then finally sharp teeth pulled at his bottom lip right before Katsuki slid inside with his tongue.

At first, the kiss had started off gentle. Soft and reassuring.

But when a chill raked down his arms, Izuku knew this was different—he could taste it. It was the silent communication of them nearing the finish line. Within their push and pull were a litany of promises for the future.

Like a spark catching fire, the kiss turned more passionate.

Not soft. Not hesitant. But as if it meant everything. Their bodies began to melt together and Katsuki stole all the air from Izuku’s lungs.

Izuku began to lose himself to everything he was feeling: the pressure of Katsuki’s mouth on his, the way his hands tilted his head just right, how his body pressed in, confident and steadfast. It was all stacking up to be something more than a kiss: it was a claim.

Katsuki leaned in, deepening the kiss with a firm push that sent Izuku gently tipping back. He didn't resist. Instead, he let himself sink into the soft pillow beneath him, arms winding around his husband to pull him closer, guiding Katsuki down on top of him.

When they slotted together, Katsuki groaned quietly in the back of his throat.

He pulled himself away from Izuku. In the dark, they both laid there, breathing heavy. Their eyes half lidded, and their lips glistening from the soft coating of saliva. Katsuki took a second to soak in the sight of him, and bit his lip.

"Do you want to?" Katsuki asked, voice so low it scraped the bottom of Izuku's core.

Izuku's toes curled at the thought.

"I do, but—" he cautiously looked at the closed door. "What if we accidentally wake someone up? I don't think I could handle the embarrassment if someone heard us."

"Don't worry," Katsuki reassured. He gently stroked Izuku's head, coaxing him into a blanket of security. "You just have to be real quiet. Can you do that for me?"

His tempting voice beckoned Izuku's arousal forward. They locked eyes, and Izuku knew he was damned then and there.

"I can do it for you, Kacchan."

"That's my darling," Katsuki grinned.

Katsuki got up from the bed and walked over to his backpack that was tucked away on the other side of the room. He dipped his hand in one pocket, and pulled out a small tube. The shape of it was very recognizable to Izuku at this point.

"When did you get lube?" Izuku questioned, slightly surprised.

"I picked it up at Midnight Sento," Katsuki replied smugly. "It's not the only thing I got in that sex shop in the basement either."

Izuku pressed his legs together, intrigued. "Wh-What else did you get?"

"I got you some more pretty panties," Katsuki teased with a mischievous undertone. He now dug in his bag and pulled out soft baby blue, delicate lace underwear. Heat burned at Izuku's cheeks at the garments, taken aback. "I had a feeling you were probably missing feeling pretty, weren't you? I know you hate wearing boxers."

Izuku blushed, but laughed. He should have known.

"Yeah, I haven't enjoyed it. But given the situation, I've adjusted."

"Well. No more adjusting to shit you don't like. I got you a couple pairs."

Katsuki kneeled on the bed, lace underwear in tow. He pushed the covers aside to reveal Izuku lying there. The oversized black shirt and boxers were loosely hanging from his frame. Under his husband's intense gaze, Izuku felt himself grow timid. The heat between them simmered as Katsuki took his time sliding off Izuku's boxers.

Izuku's half-erection twitched and the cold air tickled his skin.

Katsuki bit his lip as he began to slide on the baby blue garments. With tremendous care, he returned the decorative lace to Izuku's hips like it was always supposed to be there. Izuku drank in the softness of Katsuki's touch and the gentle feeling of normalcy the underwear provided him.

Once they were fully seated on his body, Katsuki kissed his hip bone.

"There we go." Katsuki smiled. "Absolutely goddamn perfect."

Without a moment's hesitation his husband reclaimed his spot between his legs. Warm, calloused hands massaged into his thighs and Izuku happily opened himself wider.

Their pelvises pressed together as Katsuki resumed kissing him deeply. They rocked softly, making sure not to make too much noise. It was a gentle rhythm that contrasted the last time they collided, full of brutal passion.

Izuku's stomach tightened when Katsuki's lips began to travel down. Kisses peppered along his jaw, his neck and then his sensitive collar bone. Sweetness and heat caramelized together, like every touch created a path of electricity on his skin the further and further Katsuki went.

Large, rough hands gripped his sides as Katsuki's head dipped low. Izuku watched, trying his best to keep his uneven breathing under control. Katsuki's mouth caught the hem of his shirt and peeled it up, revealing Izuku's stomach.

They made eye contact only once before Katsuki leaned down.

He placed the first kiss right above Izuku's navel. It was soft and deliberate. The touch ignited the molten feeling deep in Izuku's core. It spread, running down his legs and made his breath catch.

"I think I'd slit a thousand throats for you," Katsuki whispered against his skin, voice husky at the edges.

He planted another kiss next to his navel, this time sucking at the supple skin softly. He nipped and licked, tasting Izuku in a way that aligned with a form of worship. Tiny sparks raced down Izuku's spine. His husband's hands gripped his hips as he continued his motions. When Katsuki delicately swirled his tongue on the edges of Izuku's navel, a quiet, bashful whine spilled into the air.

He squirmed when his cock officially became fully hard. Another kiss followed, then another. Each open mouth kiss traveled across his torso in an agonizingly slow path.

Then finally Katsuki's mouth ghosted above the lace. Katsuki kissed his way down, dragging his teeth across the lace like it owed him something. Like he'd earned it. As if every inch of Izuku was meant for him.

Izuku's fists clenched the sheets.

"Katsuki…" he whispered huskily.

"I got you," Katsuki murmured, voice low and rough. His hands smoothed along the insides of Izuku's thighs, thumbs tracing lazy circles as he settled between them. "You just breathe."

Wet, slow kisses touched the tip of Izuku's cock through the lace. Izuku whined, trying to hold back. He wasn't used to not letting out his moans and the idea of them getting caught ignited something in his core. It filled him up as Katsuki pulled aside the underwear gently.

Within moments, Izuku gasped as his husband took him in his warm, awaiting mouth. His hips shuddered, and his hand instinctively threaded into blond hair.

Pleasure spilled into his core, soft and erotic as Katsuki sucked him gently. There was no rush as he bobbed his head, pulling out needy keens from Izuku's lush lips. He nuzzled in further, making Izuku curl his toes in ecstasy.

His hips jerked from intense sensitivity. Katsuki ramped up, sucking harder and breathing heavily through his nose. He reached a hand down to massage Izuku's sensitive sack. Izuku arched and his fingers tugged at delicate blond locks.

Katsuki suddenly began to devour him down like he was starving—like Izuku was decadent and not to be wasted.

His mouth was hot and unrelenting, tongue swirling with messy precision as he sucked him hard and full of fervor. Every movement dripped with hunger. He didn't slow up. He zeroed in on the tip with brutal focus, giving it a rough flick before dragging his tongue across the slit, tasting the slick proof of Izuku's need.

A guttural groan tore out of him as he took all of Izuku's cock in again, deeper this time, his throat flexing, his tongue lashing a firm, filthy lick that made Izuku's hips jerk.

"Fuck—Kacchan—" Izuku gasped. His eyes fluttered shut and his head tipped back against the pillow.

Katsuki hummed, sending vibrations like coals to rake across Izuku's nerves. The weight of Izuku's reactions fed him, and he began to move more fervidly. Izuku bucked. He gasped out as his husband poured pleasure into him. His heels dug into the mattress helplessly as Katsuki's hands began to hold him down. Izuku whined, trying to move and fuck up against the tension as his orgasm rose.

Katsuki's grasp on his hips tightened, sure to leave bruises in an effort to keep him grounded while he unraveled.

More suffocated moans caught in Izuku's throat.

He fisted blond hair tighter and tighter while his other hand scrabbled for purchase against the mattress. Desire, heat, and rapture multiplied tenfold as Katsuki began to suck on him rougher than before. Izuku bit his lip in a crazed attempt to keep from crying out and iron spilled into his mouth.

The cord snapped.

His orgasm hit like a wave breaking against his body—hot, fast, and all-consuming. He slapped a hand over his mouth as he cried out, breath ragged. He came hard, fully intense directly into Katsuki's warm mouth. The liquid spilled and he whined into his fingers as Katsuki drew back with a long powerful suck, milking him dry.

Izuku's hand trembled against his mouth as Katsuki swallowed all of his essence, eagerly. His husband looked devilish as he rose from between his legs and wiped his mouth with the back of his hand.

"You know," Katsuki quietly murmured, brushing damp curls from Izuku's forehead. "I've always loved how much you can cum in one night. It feels like I can fuckin' wring you *dry* and that's rare for a man. Did you know that?"

Izuku reached for him blindly, breathless. His hand found Katsuki's chest, fingers curling weakly in the heat of the skin.

"N-No," he whispered, lashes fluttering. "I thought that was normal."

"Not at all." Katsuki's laugh came low and deliberate, the kind that caressed skin without touching it. "You really don't know how much of a rare gem you are."

He leaned away briefly, grabbing the fresh bottle of lube from beside him. The cap clicked open with a soft pop, and Katsuki poured a generous amount into his palm. The room filled with the slick sound of his fingers working the lube.

He didn't look away as he moved to Izuku. Their gazes tethered and the tension in the room strung taut.

When Katsuki hooked a finger into the backside of the lace and peeled it aside, he let out a soft curse. Izuku's most sensitive place lay exposed beneath him, flushed and sitting alluringly between rosy cheeks. He paused for a second, to take in the sight. Then he settled between Izuku's trembling thighs, adoring and patient, like he had all the time in the world.

With aching tenderness, Katsuki carefully massaged Izuku's delicate entrance. He coaxed Izuku open like he was precious. The lube spread warm, gliding across sensitive skin. He pampered his husband slowly, taking his time to appreciate Izuku's willingness to always be with him.

Izuku's legs twitched at the contact. His thighs flexed and he raised his hips to give little needy rolls.

“There’s no rush,” Katsuki murmured, voice like honey as he leaned forward. He pressed a kiss to Izuku’s inner thigh. “We have a lifetime of this ahead of us.”

Then, he pressed in.

Both of them quietly hissed as the tip of his finger breached. Katsuki pushed in further, easing past the tight resistance with intensive care.

“Damn,” Katsuki groaned. He bit his lip as he sunk himself in at an excruciatingly slow pace. “You’re as tight as the first time all over again.”

He reeled his finger back and then slowly pushed it back in.

Ravenous need washed over Izuku. It caused him to tilt his head back with a quiet groan. The burn was faint but in a familiar way that always drove him crazy. Another finger slid in fully, and Katsuki paused, letting Izuku adjust. Katsuki watched his face, deeply in tune with the twitch of his brow and the part of his lips.

When Izuku relaxed around him, he moved again—stroking deep, slow, and steady. His two fingers curved upward with practiced ease, brushing against the soft, sensitive spot inside that made Izuku’s toes curl.

A loud whimper escaped Izuku’s throat. “Katsuki—”

“Shh, darling,” Katsuki whispered against his thigh. “Not too loud.”

He added a third finger, gentler this time. Izuku tensed, then melted as Katsuki massaged him open. A caring thumb swept soothing circles on his inner thigh. The stretch stung, but beneath the sting was intoxicating heat. It caused Izuku to claw at his belly, like he could tear it open and alleviate himself of the burning.

Katsuki continued to move with hypnotic rhythm. Expertly, his fingers scissored, stroked, and filled Izuku up. His lips brushed against Izuku’s knee, then lower to his thigh. His breath skated over the sensitive, freckled skin. He laid down a trail of kisses as his pace became quicker, fucking in and out with the squelch of the lube.

Izuku’s hips lifted, instinctive, desperate for more.

He pushed his hand into his core when he felt the heat inside of him stir high for a second time.

Katsuki smirked against his thigh. He mercilessly pressed down on that singular spot.

Izuku gasped, hands flying to fist the sheets. Katsuki sped up his movements, pressing deep, curling up until Izuku’s back arched from the bed in pure, wordless pleasure. He struck again and again and again until Izuku felt his sanity begin to drown underneath the ripples of pleasure. His legs began to quake and the smirk on his husband’s face spread wider.

“Does right here feel good?” Katsuki teased, knowing damn well it did.

“Don’t toy with me,” Izuku hissed, voice brimming with warning. “I’m already struggling to k-keep my voice down.”

He choked on his next words as several more desperate whines were pushed out of him.

“Sorry,” Katsuki whispered, voice dipping low and hungry. “You’re perfect like this. How could not play with you just a little bit?”

He leaned in and pressed soft, open-mouthed kisses to Izuku’s stomach, never breaking rhythm with his hand. The lube made every motion slick and precise. Katsuki knew exactly how to touch him, how to make him come undone with nothing but his fingers and the rough love in his voice.

Without breaking his movements, Katsuki removed his own boxers. He began to slick himself up, stroking himself as he listened to Izuku come undone. He quietly groaned into Izuku’s soft stomach as he doused his erection in a generous amount of lube, squeezing the tip.

Izuku felt himself unraveling. His thighs trembled and he bit into his knuckles when he felt a moan pushed out from another intoxicating massage of his sweet spot. His eyes screwed shut and his back arched off the bed. The pressure built fast and hot, the edge pulling him forward until—

Katsuki ripped his fingers out.

Izuku choked, breath catching in surprise. He was given no room to think before Katsuki drowned him with an overwhelming kiss.

His husband pressed his body firmly on top. And he didn’t let up—he acted as if he couldn’t control the need to be physically connected. Katsuki kissed him deeply, tongue sliding directly into his mouth sensually. It was rough, desperate, and dominating—like he needed Izuku to feel him all the way down to the bone.

His hand slid into Izuku’s curls, tugging just enough to make him shiver.

Izuku’s fingers dug into Katsuki’s shoulders, clinging like he’d fall apart otherwise.

The soft nudge of Katsuki’s thick tip caught at Izuku’s entrance. They broke the kiss, gasping softly as the pressure increased. Izuku whimpered, already biting his lip.

“I told you to keep it down, darling,” Katsuki whispered, low and firm, his voice heavy with possession. “You’ll wake the whole damn cabin.”

He nudged in the tip and Izuku roughly exhaled through his nose. When Izuku thought his mind couldn’t become more crazed, Katsuki began to push in—slow and steady. He felt every inch of Katsuki’s girth. It grew as he pushed in, spreading him open in a way that could only be described as home. The beautiful sting made Izuku wince, shuddering as his husband dove into him. Izuku’s nails bit into Katsuki’s skin and his legs wrapped around his waist.

When Katsuki bottomed out, both of them shakily moaned. Katsuki stilled for a moment, tasting the way he was hugged so deliciously. He then pulled back and eased forward again—slow, deliberate, deep.

Izuku's eyes fluttered shut, hands moving to clutch Katsuki's arms for support.

Every thrust was smooth and patient, paced to keep the bed from creaking. Every roll of his hips sent waves down Izuku's body from head to toe. They tried to keep their sounds from escaping past the room as they became lost in each other. Katsuki leaned down and sprayed soft kisses across Izuku's cheek, his temple, his parted lips—anywhere he could reach.

Izuku was trembling, doing his best to stay quiet, but a soft, broken noise slipped from his throat when Katsuki hit that perfect spot. He barely got it out before Katsuki was kissing him again, swallowing the sound whole.

"God, you're so fuckin' tight," Katsuki groaned softly against his lips. "You're killing me."

Katsuki moved with more urgency now. He thrusted in harder and dragged soft gasps and quakes from Izuku with every snap of his hips. His hands began to shake as he felt their bodies wrap into one.

Katsuki leaned back, his hips rolling faster with each thrust now. He set a relentless rhythm that sent sparks licking across Izuku's skin. Every movement pushed him closer to the edge, until it felt like he was unraveling beneath the weight of Katsuki. Of his love, of his touch, of his beautiful scarlet stare.

Izuku was full in every way now: body, heart, soul.

Katsuki was everywhere. On his skin. In his lungs. He was even gripping his hair with a steady hand that possessively tugged, letting Izuku know exactly who he was married to.

It was overwhelming.

Then suddenly, a flood of emotion crashed through him all at once. Izuku clung to Katsuki's gaze, those searing eyes locked on his like a lifeline, and it made the pleasure burn deeper into his core.

Then Katsuki thrust harder, perfectly angled and sharp with purpose. Izuku gasped. The soft cry was barely bitten down with his teeth.

Tears welled at the corners of Izuku's eyes from the intensity of it all.

"Are you okay?" Katsuki whispered quietly.

Izuku nodded, still gasping. "I—I just love you so much. I don't know what to do with it."

Katsuki's breath stuttered, catching sharp in his chest like the words physically struck him. His hips snapped forward with one deliberate thrust. He sank into Izuku until there was nothing left between them.

They both groaned in a low, raw octave.

“Shit,” Katsuki whispered. For a second, his grip loosened on Izuku’s hair. Then he leaned down until their mouths were a mere inch apart. “You don’t have to do anything with it. Give it to me—I’ll take it.”

Katsuki snapped his hips again and punched out a pretty keen from Izuku. It spilled right into Katsuki’s open mouth. He did it again, and again, and again until he found a luscious rhythm. Their rugged breaths mingled, interwinding like vines back and forth as pleasure rocked through their bodies.

Katsuki moved like he was guiding a storm and taming it all at once. Each punch of his hips was measured but heavy with intent, raw and passionate, like he wanted Izuku to feel him—not only physically, but spiritually. He wanted to seer himself into Izuku’s every aching, sensitive nerve.

Izuku clung to him as if gravity had turned sideways. His hands slipped along the solid curve of Katsuki’s back, nails scratching down as he tried to anchor himself through the storm of rapture Katsuki pushed him into. Every slide, every grind of pressure sent shivers tearing through him, breath catching in soft, desperate sounds that Izuku muffled with the grit of his teeth.

Then with one, powerful thrust, Izuku was utterly blindsided by pleasure. His head tilted against the pillow, and his body arched off the bed.

And he moaned—*loudly*.

The erotic sound reverberated through the room as absolute rapture electrocuted his mind.

Quickly, Katsuki slapped a hand over his mouth, but didn’t stop. They locked eyes, intense and heady as Katsuki continued to drive in and out at a brutal pace. The lewd, muffled moans vibrated against Katsuki’s palm, and Izuku uncontrollably twitched beneath the waves crashing down through him.

“Fu-fuck,” Katsuki hissed, hips stuttering.

He clasped his hand tighter around Izuku’s mouth as his pace picked up. Izuku screwed his eyes shut as he held on tightly to his husband and moaned helplessly into his hand.

Pure, carnal hunger devoured them whole as Katsuki began to fuck him like their lives depended on it. Izuku felt every slam against his sweet spot down to his core and the heat piled high. The bed creaked, rocked, and it hit the wall in tandem with their rhythm.

Katsuki muffled his own groans by burying himself in the crook of Izuku’s neck. Sweat beads gathered at their brows as both of their arms and legs began to shake.

Izuku felt himself climb high, he gasped into his husband’s hand as Katsuki somehow found a way to drive into him with more fervor.

Then the second wave came. He felt it stack tall, swelling in pressure and intensity under his skin like a gathering inferno until it exploded.

Izuku's mind went blank.

He whined lewdly into Katsuki's hand and his nails drew blood as they raked down his husband's back. His whole body seized up beautifully as euphoria danced along his skin. He clamped down on his husband's pulsing cock and Katsuki followed closely behind.

A needy groan was muffled into Izuku's neck and the hand on his mouth tightened. Izuku's legs quaked as he came. His essence spilled between their bodies, soaking the lace and shortly after, Katsuki filled him up. His husband gave one, two, three hard thrusts before his hips stuttered. Then he sank in for a final, powerful drive.

Warm seed spread all over Izuku's insides, making him groan as he felt Katsuki's cock twitch, giving him every last drop.

For a long moment, neither of them moved. Katsuki didn't pull out right away, and Izuku didn't want him to.

The room was heavy with the scent of sweat and sex. The quiet rush of blood in their ears pulsed against the dead of night. Izuku was completely pliant, like putty. Together, their chests were rising and falling in uneven waves.

Slowly, Katsuki's hand moved away from his mouth and found its way around Izuku's throat. Firm. Not choking, but just there. A reminder to Izuku of who exactly Katsuki was.

Gradually, the haze of pleasure bled out into tenderness.

With delicate care, Katsuki pulled out. He watched Izuku's face closely for any sign of pain.

Izuku winced, but barely. The look in his eyes was soft, glowing in the pale moonlight. Katsuki reached for a nearby towel and cleaned them both with slow, gentle movements.

Then he laid down beside him, tugging Izuku into his arms. He held Izuku tightly, like he couldn't bear to ever let go. Without a word, their legs tangled as they came down from the moment. They encased each other, and their bodies became their own private shelter for the night.

Quietly, Katsuki pressed his lips to Izuku's damp forehead. He murmured something too quiet for Izuku to catch. Izuku then turned in, and buried his face in Katsuki's warm chest. He hummed low at the erratic beating of his husband's heart. He quietly listened to it slow down, and carefully he wrapped his arms around Katsuki's waist.

He clung tight like the world might shift beneath them if he let go.

They stayed this way for a while. Breathing together. Heartbeats syncing.

Katsuki's fingers threaded through Izuku's curls.

“Are you okay?” he asked softly. “That was really intense.”

Izuku nodded. He pressed a kiss to Katsuki’s sternum. “Yeah. I feel really…full. Not just from, uh, you know. But from everything. I just really love you so much.”

Katsuki’s throat bobbed.

“Yeah,” he whispered. “I know what you mean. I love you too.”

Silence fell over them again like an extra blanket. It was heavy and warm. Exactly what they needed for the dead of night. Katsuki’s arms flexed tighter around Izuku as he exhaled through his nose. Gradually, he let his eyes slip shut.

“You scare the shit out of me sometimes,” Katsuki whispered after a beat. “You make me feel too much.”

“Same.” Izuku looked up, eyes glassy but warm.

Katsuki gave a soft hum. It was pulled from somewhere deep in his chest and full of never ending love. He kissed the corner of Izuku’s mouth, then again, slower, on his temple.

“To reiterate: I’m not going anywhere, ever, Izuku,” Katsuki whispered. “You don’t have to carry anything alone anymore. I’ll take all of it—your love, your fear, even your bad dreams. Everything.”

Izuku’s arms wound even tighter around him. “Promise?”

Katsuki didn’t hesitate. “Yeah. I promise.”

And they stayed curled like that for the rest of the night. The world outside their little cocoon remained quiet and still for this fleeting moment. Izuku finally relaxed, bones undoing for the first time in a long time.

As snow continued to gently fall outside their window, they closed their eyes. Skin to skin, breath to breath—two hearts finally at rest.

When morning rolled around, Izuku felt like a brand-new man. He had been revitalized, and practically exfoliated by the bliss of sleeping without fear clinging to his spine.

This felt different than the night after the masquerade. Then, he was dripped in such an ugly darkness that forced him to shed his old skin and accept that he wasn’t a viper—and never had been. But this breath of fresh air was lighter. He felt like he had finally found the path to light with the help of Katsuki guiding him like some guardian angel.

Izuku got dressed in the clothes that were laid out for him from Aizawa. It was a simple, beige sweater and sweatpants. Katsuki had on his own black sweats.

Shy smiles were exchanged between them as they headed out of the room.

They followed the lovely scent of breakfast into the kitchen. Awaiting him were all the faces he had come to know the previous day. And not one of their gazes had changed from the last time Izuku had seen them.

Miruko smiled. Denki offered a lazy wave. Monoma lifted two fingers in a half-hearted salute. Aizawa was reading something. Shinsou didn't even glance up from his plate.

Izuku suddenly felt inexplicably shy.

He lingered a step behind Katsuki, offering a small nod of greeting before they both took their seats at the long dining table. The spread before them was enough to make his mouth water on command: pancakes, fruit, grilled salmon, onigiri, and an array of fresh vegetables. The scent was rich and comforting.

And then, as if his body had been waiting for permission, Izuku's stomach let out a long, loud growl.

Izuku startled, surprised. He bashfully grabbed his abdomen.

"Sorry about that," he apologized. "I guess I didn't realize how hungry I am."

"Dig in until you feel satisfied," Miruko laughed. She smiled happily with a radiant expression. "We're all just getting started. Coffee is over there on the counter."

"I'm about to drink that entire pot," Katsuki grumbled as he reached for two plates. He placed one down in front of Izuku and began to fill his plate for him. He easily grabbed everything he knew Izuku liked: pancakes, eggs, and salmon. He even made sure to give him extra strawberries on the side.

"You got tea?" Katsuki asked Aizawa. "Izuku doesn't like coffee."

The comment earned a few subtle looks from around the table.

"There's some in the cabinet above the stove," Aizawa replied, pointing directly behind him.

While Katsuki went to retrieve it, Izuku reached for Katsuki's plate and filled it for him in the same manner. He made sure to pile on things he knew Katsuki loved: salmon, waffles, and anything that leaned into the spicier flavors he gravitated towards.

Across the table, Denki was stifling a laugh.

"Damn," he said, smirking. "You really know what he likes, huh?"

Izuku paused, unsure why that was funny. "Yes?"

"Mhm." Denki bit his lip and then a jester-like grin split across his face. "So. You were knocked out for the whole day yesterday. Did you have a nice *pleasure-filled* sleep?"

Izuku dropped the fork. He choked on his own saliva and Katsuki whirled around, mortified. All color drained from both of their faces and Izuku wished the ground would split open to

swallow them whole.

Denki bursted into harmonious laughter with Sero.

Miruko tried to hide her own, small smile while Monoma elbowed Denki in the side. Shinsou sighed and continued to eat his bacon, biting aggressively into it. His face translated nothing but pure, absolute irritation.

“Don’t embarrass them,” Miruko lectured, though her own smirk betrayed her. “Slip ups happen, especially at 3:00 a.m. Everyone knows the two things open at that time of night are legs and liquor stores.”

“I-I’m so sorry!” Izuku blurted out. He frantically bowed his head as his cheeks burned with pure embarrassment. “Th-That was completely inappropriate of us to do with everyone in the house—”

“—Relax,” Miruko chuckled, placing a calming hand over his. “Not everyone heard. It was just me and Kaminari. And I didn’t hear the whole thing. Only one… *very* loud moan. Personally, I shot up because I was on edge. I thought the Yakuza had somehow gotten in and were murdering Bakugou—but. Turns out it was quite the opposite when I checked near your room.”

“Yeah, and I woke up when I heard your bed knocking,” Denki snickered. “You’re lucky it’s me you share a wall with and not prude number one and two over there.” He jabbed his thumb towards Monoma and Shinsou. “They probably would’ve interrupted you guys mid thrust. But luckily, I understand how the throws of passion can’t be tamed.”

Izuku made a noise somewhere between a dying kettle and a gasping goldfish.

Katsuki returned with his tea, face a deep red. They awkwardly shifted next to each other while Denki continued to howl like a hyena.

“New house rule,” Aizawa suddenly announced. He sat his cup of coffee down on the table sternly and shot Katsuki a chastising glare. “Please try not to fondle each other while we’re forced to all stay here. No more three a.m. moans and no hand jobs on the living room couch where people can walk in and see.”

Katsuki frowned. “Uh. We didn’t do that last one.”

“I know,” Aizawa deadpanned, turning his glare on Denki and Sero. “It was these two.”

In a second, the laughter in the room died down to only Miruko. Sero rubbed his neck and Denki sucked in his lips.

“All of you are bad for my blood pressure,” Aizawa curtly declared. He shook his head, clearly too old for all of this, as he turned his attention back on his paperwork. He picked up his pen and began aggressively writing. “Listen. I know you’re all young, energetic twenty-somethings but for the love of *god*—try to spare the rest of us.”

Izuku was mortified. “I’m so sorry—”

“—It’s fine,” Aizawa grumbled. He raised his hand to silence Izuku. “I blame Bakugou more than you. Let’s not discuss it. Ever.”

Izuku gave a slow nod.

The weight of ten thousand pounds worth of mortification pressed down on him. So much for making a good first impression.

He kept his gaze locked on his plate, cheeks burning, and did the one thing that made sense at that moment: he ate. If his mouth was full, he couldn’t accidentally make this situation worse, right? So he focused on chewing, fork moving on autopilot, piling bite after bite in like it was a shield against further humiliation.

As if what had happened was a normal occurrence, breakfast carried on. Everyone at the table blended into one with a kind of gentle laughter Izuku wasn’t accustomed to.

The table buzzed with easy banter, light as morning air, flowing between everyone like they’d done this a thousand times. It was effortless, familiar. His heart swelled at the sight of Katsuki slipping so naturally into it all. These were his husband’s longtime colleagues, but Izuku hadn’t fully grasped until now exactly how close they truly were.

Monoma and Katsuki traded barbs with the ease of old rivals, sharp in tone but soft in intent. Denki and Sero kept the energy high, tossing jokes back and forth while Miruko’s bright, melodic laughter filled the room. Shinsou chimed in with comments of wisdom, keeping everyone grounded.

At the head of the table, Aizawa remained mostly silent. He offered the occasional dry scoff or exasperated glance—but Izuku caught the serene, satisfied smile that tugged at his lips as he watched over the group. Especially when his eyes landed on Katsuki.

Aizawa flicked his wrist as he signed something on the papers in front of him.

Katsuki’s curiosity was tugged. He leaned over, trying to get a better look.

“What’s that?” He asked outright.

Aizawa gave another quick signature on the paper before double checking it. “I was finishing going over the final details of Izuku’s case.”

At that, Izuku paused his eating. He peered over to Aizawa as everyone looked at him.

“My case?” He clarified.

“Yup. You’re officially a client of ours.” Aizawa then reached down and pulled out a green folder from under his seat. He neatly tucked away the papers inside and held it up. “Congrats.”

Izuku stared at the folder, taken aback. He had never seen a green folder before. Did Aizawa color it this way because of his hair and eyes? Izuku curiously touched his curls at this moment, unsure of what green could mean.

“Thank you so much,” Izuku said, deeply sincere. “I’ll go get my money—”

“—No need. We’re doing this pro-bono,” Aizawa replied firmly.

Izuku paused. He was unsure if he liked that.

“A-Are you positive?” He questioned. “I don’t have much, but I can still give you some compensation for your time.”

“Don’t sweat it. Consider this a belated wedding gift.”

Aizawa pointedly looked at Katsuki who quietly mouthed ‘thank you’.

“But before we make it official, there are some things I want to hash out,” Aizawa remarked. “Yesterday, while you were sleeping, Katsuki filled us in on some of the details we were still missing—but it would be helpful if you could add more color to this.”

“Of course,” Izuku eagerly agreed. He sat up straight and politely folded his hands. “I’ll tell you anything you want to know.”

“You said that they issued an email blast that detailed a hunt for you,” Aizawa pondered. He then scratched his chin with his finger and pursed his lips. “But you also said Katsuki is the only one that they want dead and mentioned your brother’s plans hinge on you being present. Is it solely because he sold Chisaki your virginity? Because obviously—” he gestured at Katsuki. “—That is off the table. Is there more to it?”

Izuku nervously toyed with his hands. “There’s—There’s more.”

Unprompted, his throat became dry.

As he gazed at all the prying eyes, his nerves rattled like someone shook him. Opening up was something he was still practicing—but this was much different than talking with Katsuki. With his husband, it felt easy, like a flowing river. But with people he didn’t know—he wasn’t sure.

“It’s okay,” Katsuki suddenly said. “You can tell them.”

He put his hands over Izuku’s and encased them tenderly.

Green eyes met red and they held each other’s gaze for a comforting moment. There, Izuku felt like Katsuki leant him his strength simply by looking deep into his eyes. Izuku blinked a couple times. Katsuki smiled.

Izuku then looped his gaze back at Aizawa and never let go of Katsuki’s hands.

“My brother, Tomura, had plans to try to marry me off to Chisaki Kai.”

At this, silence rippled through the group. Spines straightened. Eyes narrowed and the laughter from moments before became distant.

“Marry?” Aizawa parroted like he heard wrong. “To the Yakuza Heir?”

“Ye-Yeah,” Izuku whispered. He swallowed thickly when the tension in the room became serious. “Right before I escaped, Tomura confessed he set up the virginity deal to bring me and Chisaki closer. He thought it would slowly devolve into dates and then eventually a marriage proposal. But—clearly that’s not how that night went.”

“But why would he make you marry Chisaki?” Miruko asked, horrified. “What sense does that make?”

“It would meld the Vipers to the Yakuza in a permanent, unprecedented way that shows loyalty,” Izuku explained. “If the Vipers merged with the Yakuza, we’ll be on somewhat equal footing as two crime families in the Tokyo Underground coming together. Tomura will be Chisaki’s brother-in-law and he’ll be able to gain more access to power. And that’s all he ever wanted—power. Power to run The Viper Academy. Power to sit at the Underground Council. And now, power through the Yakuza.”

“Why doesn’t he marry Chisaki his damn self then?” Monoma spat.

“Because Chisaki has a type.” Izuku grew quiet here. “My brother’s face is too marred to be attractive to Chisaki—and he exudes too much dominant energy. Chisaki is obsessed with purity. People who seem…*innocent* and submissive. But, it’s extremely rare for someone to catch Chisaki Kai’s eye. The last person who did was some civilian school teacher. Chisaki had the man kidnapped and delivered to his doorstep. He wasn’t seen again. I’m the second person he’s openly shown interest in and it seems like he’s trying to repeat history.”

It was here Izuku could see Shinsou carefully look at his features, picking them apart.

“What the Yakuza Heir wants, he gets,” Aizawa remarked, matter of fact. “No matter who pays the price. And I’m assuming your brother is the same way if they are friends.”

“He is. But for Tomura, if I marry Chisaki Kai, he’ll be able to take control of all the Tokyo Underground,” Izuku said. “He’ll overrun Chisaki in record timing, I’m sure. Exactly like he did with our previous handler, Nine. Tomura is good at gaining peoples’ favor to stab them in the back later.”

“But I don’t see what Chisaki would get out of this,” Denki said. “Besides arm candy, he has to see he’s being used, right? Why would he ever agree to marry you, you two barely know each other.”

“Chisaki doesn’t care about getting to know me,” Izuku replied, a tinge sour. “I’m an object to him. That man wants to possess me. Not all marriages are about companionship. Many are business deals and that’s exactly how Tomura will pitch me to him: a business deal that likely could benefit him.”

“—And the Yakuza have very rarely done love marriages,” Aizawa tacked on, deep in thought. “The closest I can think of a love match in the Yakuza is when the Heir gets obsessed with someone and they force them. If they don’t go that route, they strictly get married to someone that gives them some sort of political or economic gain.”

“So you would be both,” Monoma said slowly, as if it all clicked together. “Damn. You really struck out.”

Izuku furrowed his brow.

The more he sat on it, the more terrible sense it made.

He had to give it to his brother. Tomura wielded his ruthless intelligence like a scalpel—precise, surgical, and devoid of anything resembling mercy.

“Chisaki’s whole empire was built on merges, that’s why he’s so powerful,” Izuku reasoned out loud. “He’s successfully merged all the other Yakuza syndicates into his. And honestly, the more I consider it, it wouldn’t be far fetched for him to want to absorb the Vipers. He works so closely with us it actually seems natural. I know he’s always been put off about how much he has to pay for Viper assassins. If he absorbed us, he wouldn’t have to pay for our services anymore I’m assuming.”

“And there’s the fact Chisaki is spoiled rotten to the core,” Miruko spat, disgusted. “I met the guy once, when he came to check out our own services—and man. He’s apathetic about everything. The few times he showed real emotion was when he got to play with people like toys. Or when he was angry about being disrespected. He fully believes he’s entitled to full access to the very best things, at all moments.”

“And because of your looks…” Sero whispered, eyes finally seeing the full picture. “…He probably believes he’s entitled to you.”

“Yeah,” Izuku replied. “I don’t know what I would do if I somehow ended up being forced to marry Chisaki,” Izuku lamented. He hung his head away. “I would feel like I died inside. I-I want to survive, but if that happened, that’s not a life I could go on living.”

Izuku noticed how Katsuki was quiet during this whole exchange. With every further and further mention of Chisaki, anger swam around in his eyes, searching for a way out.

“Alright, well thank you Izuku for giving us the full gravity of this situation,” Aizawa said.

Aizawa rose from his chair with the green folder tucked under one arm, his expression sharpened into steel. His gaze swept across the table, pausing on each face—taking inventory. When it landed on Izuku, a flicker of determination locked into place.

“This is a level ten protection case,” Aizawa declared. His voice was low but weighty, the kind of tone that silenced the entire room. “Given that this is the Yakuza we’re dealing with, I have brought Miruko on board to help out. The objective of this mission: under absolutely no circumstances does Izuku get taken by the Vipers or Yakuza. And if he does—we’re extracting him. As a unit, we’re going to make sure these two make it to the escape point in Okinawa.”

He crossed the short distance to Katsuki and handed him the folder. Katsuki took it without hesitation, fingers closing around it like it was something holy.

“This is officially your last green folder assignment, kid,” Aizawa warned. “Make it count.”

Katsuki gave a single nod, stiff with purpose.

Izuku swallowed. Before he could stop himself he asked, “What does green mean?”

Silence folded over the room. Everyone turned towards him.

Katsuki didn’t let go of his hand. Instead, he gripped it tighter until Izuku could feel the pulse in his husband’s fingertips against his skin. When Katsuki’s voice came, it was rough and certain.

“Green means to protect.”

The weight of the words landed like a gun being cocked. Final. Fatal, if they had to be.

Now, their intertwined hands were clasped tight enough for Izuku to feel all of Katsuki’s burning hatred for Chisaki. Katsuki was looking at him, eyes full of fire. The muscle in his jaw flexed with barely restrained fury. He didn’t say anything further—and he didn’t need to.

The expression on his face alone said enough: *Over my dead body.*

Chapter End Notes

Thank you so much for reading!!! I hope you enjoyed. The next chapter is pretty silly stuff because writing more silly M-Unit stuff feels like it was needed before I push you all over the final ledge. :')

Have a great rest of your day!

Chapter 36: Tacet

Chapter Summary

Tacet (Instrumentation Instructions) Indicates a musical instrument to rest.

Chapter Notes

Hello! Welcome back to this lovely story :') Early update because sitting on this is making me too excited in anticipation lol here's a fun chapter for you! I hope you enjoy it!! Thank you like always to the LOML, Luna, for being a beta beast!! ❤️❤️❤️

Warnings: Adult Scenes and Themes

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 36 — Tacet

.

.

.

Aizawa's decree echoed in Izuku's ears. It felt like a war cry, in a way. Izuku could only hope Tomura didn't hear it wherever he was.

He made sure to express his gratitude. He bowed low, and muttered "thank you" as many times as Aizawa would let him. It was only after the tenth time did Aizawa tell him to ease up and go back to eating.

He tried to do exactly that, but underneath all the eyes, he was awkwardly hyper-aware of his body. He credited the discomfort to being so close to freedom. It was surreal that soon his body would be that—his. He was overly thankful that Aizawa had taken him in. If he didn't —Izuku wouldn't know what to do. He didn't have anyone else now to depend upon.

Before they could wrap up breakfast, Aizawa tapped him on the shoulder.

"Izuku," he spoke. "I wanted to talk to you in private after you finish with your food."

Izuku straightened out his back and nodded eagerly. "Of course, sir."

“Please, don’t call me sir.” Aizawa frowned. “I’m not that old despite what your smart aleck husband tells you.”

A couple of chuckles rolled through the group along with a quip from Katsuki.

After Izuku finished with his meal, Aizawa gently gestured for him to get up. Without haste, both Izuku and Aizawa arose from the kitchen table. Aizawa led the way while Izuku followed. Nervously, Izuku swallowed and clasped his hands behind his back. This must be the final interrogation.

They reached the drawing room and it welcomed them with its velvety purples.

Aizawa took a seat first, then motioned for Izuku to do the same with a calm, unreadable expression.

Izuku obeyed, hesitantly sitting down in the armchair directly across from him.

The silence between them stretched, heavy and uncomfortable. Aizawa studied him with a gaze crafted by years of instinct and mistrust, and Izuku felt every second of it. His thoughts spiraled under that quiet stare—was Aizawa seeing a monster? A threat? A boy who had dragged Katsuki into something far darker than he ever deserved?

Maybe he saw all of it—because Izuku certainly did.

Aizawa exhaled. “I wanted to ask you about someone your agency—” he paused, eyes flickering as he corrected himself. “I mean, I wanted to ask you about someone your *family* murdered.”

“Yes,” Izuku stammered. He nodded, biting the inside of his cheek. “And ‘agency’ is fine. I’ll give you any information you may want.”

“Do you happen to know of a case pertaining to an agent by the name of Loud Cloud?”

It rang a bell. Izuku’s eyes sparked with a flicker of recognition. Aizawa caught it.

“So. You do know,” Aizawa muttered, his jaw tightening. He leaned back slowly. “Tell me.”

“I’ve only heard that name once,” Izuku answered carefully. “I heard of him this year when I was in Okinawa with Katsuki. My brother, Tomura, mentioned that name after going on a trip to Czechia.”

Aizawa huffed a humorless laugh. A faint smirk curled his lips as if he’d found a missing puzzle piece.

“I think I’ve met your brother then.”

“White hair with endless viper tattoos?” Izuku questioned.

“Yup.” Aizawa confirmed and scoffed. “That’s the guy. If that’s who your brother is, then your story makes a lot more sense.”

Izuku was curious now. Tomura had mentioned Czechia was a mess for him and One, all because of someone with a thirty year long grudge. But Izuku was more impressed with how Aizawa managed to even get close to One and Tomura and still live to tell the tale.

This guy must've been a force to be reckoned with.

"How did you find them?" Izuku asked, unable to contain the wonder in his voice.

Aizawa shrugged, entirely nonchalant. "I remember my friend mentioning something about working with a 'Viper' right before he went missing. And with a stroke of luck, I had a new client this year. He mentioned that we were 'sloppy' in comparison to 'Vipers'. So I decided to waterboard him to get a lead. He gave me your picture, along with a couple of others, plus the location of where your founder, One, would be heading next for a meeting—which was Czechia."

Izuku nearly whistled. Impressive was an understatement.

"I'm sorry," Izuku muttered. "I'm truly sorry for what they did to him."

Now, Aizawa leaned forward. A menacing scowl eclipsed his face. "I want to know *why*."

Izuku's throat went dry. He swallowed, and did his best to push past the lock on his throat.

"Our Grand Father…" He paused. He closed his eyes and sighed. "I mean, our founder, One. He was trying to snuff out competition. He didn't want to straight out slaughter people, because it would come off as too aggressive. So he began setting up competitors on lethal assignments to get killed. It would make the competition look incompetent while also diminishing any other agents on the field."

Aizawa's brows pulled together.

He leaned backwards and his expression hardened. "It wasn't…personal?"

Izuku shook his head mournfully. "It wasn't. I'm sorry."

"Damn," Aizawa scoffed. Then slowly, he laughed. He laughed like he had been told some cruel, unfortunate joke at his own expense. He ran a shaky hand through his hair. "This whole time I thought it was some sort of grand, crazy reason. But it was just snakes being snakes."

Izuku lowered his eyes, feeling guilty by association. "You'd been searching for a long time, haven't you?"

"I have," Aizawa affirmed heavily. He then looked Izuku in his eye and there was a new level of trust there. "Thank you."

"Of course," Izuku replied. He waited for a second, and tried to think of all the ways he could probably repay Aizawa. He could only offer one, taboo thing. "Are you going to try to seek revenge? I can try to give you any information you may need. Or even sketch out floor plans of The Academy—"

“—No.” Aizawa’s voice cut through the air like a blade.

He frowned like what Izuku suggested was equivalent to eating rotten fruit.

“I only want to know so I could tell his family,” Aizawa explained. “They’ve been waiting for years to find out what happened to him, and I wanted to give them peace. His mother made me promise when I was much younger to find out what occurred—and now I have.”

Izuku was taken back, surprised that an offer to get even was passed upon.

“Revenge isn’t the best path in life,” Aizawa lectured. He leveled Izuku with a stern scowl and shook his head. “I’ve been trying to teach Katsuki that, even though I’m not sure how well that teaching has stuck with him. Those goddamn Bakugous, Mitsuki and Katsuki alike, were always such a spiteful pair.”

Izuku pursed his lips.

Aizawa was right. Katsuki was spiteful. Hell, he was certain that spite is what drove Katsuki the last five years. However, when he thought back to Midnight Sento, Katsuki made it clear he was giving up his mission to kill Chisaki in favor of getting them to safety.

That night, his husband had traded vengeance for love.

“Katsuki seems to have let go of his need for revenge, for now at least,” Izuku murmured.

“Surprisingly, yes,” Aizawa replied. He leaned back and examined Izuku carefully. “But only because of you.”

“I didn’t really do anything. Honestly, I encouraged it.”

“You’re a Bakugou now, so it’s not surprising that you have a spiteful streak too,” Aizawa hummed. “But I think your presence in Katsuki’s life has made a good impact. Seems like being around you makes Katsuki slow down, for once in his damn life.”

Izuku didn’t know what to say. He wasn’t used to such compliments.

“Thank you,” he settled for and smiled politely.

“I mean it,” Aizawa replied. “You’re a good influence on him and he’s good for you too. You balance each other out, in a roundabout way. But you need to keep true to your word and keep that hothead safe, alright? If you don’t—”

His eyes narrowed, sharp and threatening.

“—I’ll track you down. No matter where Nana hides you.”

Izuku cracked a small, nervous smile. “Duly noted.”

“Alright then,” Aizawa muttered, rising with a grunt. “Let’s get you back downstairs before that husband of yours comes storming up here.”

Izuku smiled, picturing that perfectly in his head.

They stood together and a hush of unspoken trust settled between them. They made their way downstairs, back into the warmth and noise of the living room where the rest of their crew was awaiting them.

ᔓᔓᔓ

The moment Izuku returned to the kitchen, Katsuki instantly perked up. It made Izuku's heart flutter, and he sat back down next to his husband happily. Without waiting a second, Katsuki's hand naturally fell on top of his, and their fingers entangled the same as their lives.

Everyone watched, still eating, but assessing.

When Aizawa sat back down, he nodded once at Miruko. She returned the same gesture. Her eyes flickered to Izuku, and inside of them he could see thankfulness.

The morning concluded without note, and everyone went on about their days.

Izuku kept tightly glued to Katsuki, while outside Monoma and Shinsou disappeared into the forest in search of firewood. Inside, Denki and Sero were hunched over the kitchen counter, scribbling out a long grocery list peppered with debates over snacks and survival essentials.

Meanwhile, Aizawa and Miruko settled on opposite ends of the kitchen table, laptops perched on the wooden surface. "Admin stuff," was all they muttered when asked. From the quick taps of keys and clipped answers, it was clear they were closing out assignments before the cabin swallowed them whole for the next five and a half weeks.

Katsuki eventually settled in on the couch, and Izuku joined him. They clicked on the TV and found the closest soap opera that was entertaining. But after a couple of drama-filled episodes, Izuku admittedly became antsy.

"What are we supposed to do for the rest of our time here?" Izuku asked quietly.

"We rest," Katsuki replied simply.

He threw a lazy arm around Izuku's shoulders and hugged him tight.

Rest, huh?

Izuku hadn't considered that.

ᔓᔓᔓ

The afternoon went by and it turned out his body wasn't finished sleeping.

After sitting still a bit longer, Izuku knocked out on the couch beside Katsuki. They were only woken up for dinner, and immediately after they ate, drowsiness kicked in again. Izuku

felt lethargic, but was glad he had the space to feel such a thing. Him and his husband retired to their bedroom earlier than anticipated.

Izuku found himself in a deep, lovely uninterrupted sleep.

When he roused again, he rubbed his eyes and yawned.

He glanced at the clock and noticed it was late at night. Suddenly, his stomach rumbled loudly. He sighed as he clutched at it, and the first thing his brain supplied him was a vision of the extra strawberries in the fridge. Izuku decided a quick, midnight snack couldn't hurt.

Quietly, he crawled out of bed, careful not to wake Katsuki. His husband was still sound asleep, blond hair spread beautifully across the pillow case. Izuku smiled and tucked him in further, happy when his love shifted in the bed and snuggled further in.

Izuku crept towards the kitchen. He pictured the strawberries and found himself humming in delight. He strolled down the dark hallway past several of the other's doors.

On his way, he couldn't help but notice the picture frames on the walls. Many were of a woman with bright brown eyes and dark hair. She was smiling in most of them, standing with a boy who looked to be in his early twenties. Izuku tilted his head at one of the photos he passed by. In this one in particular he could see the boy resembled Aizawa, far more than Sero did.

"—But he's dangerous, Aizawa."

Izuku stopped.

He turned to the door next to him where the whispers echoed from. Beneath the wooden frame, a faint, yellow glow spilled out onto the floor.

"I know. But from the looks of it, I don't think he would hurt Katsuki."

"He's already killed Mitsuki, who's to say he's not trying to finish off the blood line?"

"Shinsou, that's a bit far-fetched."

Izuku's heart squeezed. He tried to move his feet, but he was glued in place.

Shinsou groaned, frustrated.

"I know—But I don't like this, Aizawa. Maybe if he was a kid or someone who hasn't already killed hundreds of people, he would be worth saving because there would be something *left* to save. But he's a grown man. His view of the world is warped, there's not a chance he can learn to be a part of society. He's brainwashed all the way through for all we know."

Izuku's heart kicked up, fast and uneven.

Suddenly Denki's voice cut in. "Do you think he has some sort of killer sleeper mode that's activated when a code word is said?" he asked in a failed whisper. "Kind of like Winter Soldier? What if it's some sort of snake name that makes him go batshit."

"Probably," Shinsou grumbled. "He's a weapon. Not a person. He even has his serial number on his damn collar bone."

Izuku raised a hand to touch his tattoo.

His callouses traced the raised skin, outlining the '217' that would be forever etched on him. He realized he hadn't thought about his number in weeks. That was the longest he had ever forgotten about it.

"He is a person, Shinsou." Now, it was Monoma's voice, defending him. "That's very unfair to say. And that sleeper agent shit is a myth—there's no science behind it."

Denki started arguing Monoma down, convinced that there were hundreds of sleeper agents walking among civilians. Izuku knew this was false, and he was not some sort of machine that had no control of his actions.

However, Shinsou interrupted all the hypotheticals with one more jab to Izuku.

"Look, sleeper agent or not," Shinsou uttered. "All I am saying is that we are trying to help a guy who grew up in a killer cult acclimate into the world. What happens if he doesn't know how? Who knows what he'll do to Katsuki later down the line. He might be the death of him. Izuku is not normal."

"But he's trying to be," Monoma murmured. "That has to count for something."

"He can try all he wants," Shinsou replied. "Snakes might shed their skin but they don't change their patterns."

Izuku took a step back.

He slipped into the shadows, letting the darkness swallow his figure. Inexplicable pain shot through him from all over as his heart squeezed.

He turned quickly on his heels, unable to listen to another word and went right back from where he came. With shaky hands he opened the bedroom door and closed it quietly behind him. His hunger was now gone, swept away underneath the wave of shame that spread across his limbs.

He stood there, back against the door staring at the room.

Shinsou's criticisms echoed through his skull.

Then quickly, Tomura's.

While he was learning there was a lot wrong with the Viper teachings, some truth still rang true. And now, the biggest teaching was ringing louder and louder: outsiders would regard

them as monsters.

Katsuki stirred and reached for the space where he should be. His husband groaned and sat up, confused. Sleep heavy eyes searched around the room, and when they found him, Katsuki smiled.

“Come back to bed, nerd,” his groggy voice drawled. It pulled Izuku in and calmed his erratic heart.

Izuku climbed under the covers, feeling safe again. He curled into Katsuki and Katsuki snuggled back. Three soft kisses were planted on his nose, cheek and mouth before his husband laid his head back down.

Izuku held on tighter.

He knew he would never hurt Katsuki—but the idea that others couldn’t see that, pained him. He wished he could unzip his skin and crawl out of everything he used to be, leaving that ugly 217 behind. But he knew he couldn’t do such a thing.

The words began to repeat.

He was not normal.

He was dangerous.

He might be the death of Katsuki.

Izuku blinked up at the ceiling. His eyes stung from holding back tears. He wanted so badly to be normal. Not only for Katsuki—but really, for himself.

His husband shifted slightly in his sleep and tucked his arm tighter around Izuku’s waist. He mumbled something unintelligible into the curve of Izuku’s neck. With that simple gesture, Katsuki’s warmth cut through Izuku’s dull ache like sun through fog.

Maybe Monoma was right. Maybe trying had to count for something. Maybe it didn’t matter how the odds were stacked or if Shinsou never changed his mind. Maybe he didn’t need the whole world to believe he could be human. Maybe he only needed to become someone who believed it himself.

Izuku closed his eyes.

“I’ll try,” he whispered, barely audible. “I’ll try my best to be normal.”

Katsuki’s hand flexed gently against his back like he’d heard it in a dream. After that, Izuku didn’t move again.

He laid there, curled into the safety of Katsuki’s arms, and let the pain ebb into quiet determination.

Week One in Winter Paradise

The first few days of getting to know Katsuki's friends were awkward. Izuku could see every glance they tossed his way held a question. They were analyzing his every move. He didn't blame them, and frankly, he understood the distrust. He just wished there was a way to win them over.

Over these first days, he learned that this particular group minus Miruko were called 'M-Unit'.

They were Aizawa's specially handpicked agents, and Izuku realized they mirrored the Viper Seven in a way. He could practically feel the favoritism. He learned that each person was responsible for a different aspect on the team.

Denki was in charge of electronics. He had a freakish depth of knowledge for anything relating to tech. The way he chatted about these things made Izuku see Aoyama in him, slightly. But only if Aoyama was a more outgoing, loud, perverted personality.

Next he learned Sero was specialized in staging and body clean up. Aizawa's nephew had apparently taken a liking to true crime podcasts when he was younger. He would ramble about them to his classmates in depth, but it caused him to become a bit of a social outcast. Eventually, the obsession devolved into gaining morbid interests regarding how killers disposed of bodies. After a while, and with the help of a lot of blackmail, Aizawa took him on.

Next were Monoma and Shinsou, which Izuku learned he had heard of before. He had seen their aliases in the news a couple of times: The Phantom Killer and The Puppet Master. He learned here that they used to work for another Hit-for-hire agency, but murdered their supervisor in cold blood once they discovered he had a thing for hurting kids.

Izuku wordlessly nodded in approval at that.

He hated kids being hurt too. If Shinsou wasn't giving him the cold shoulder so bluntly, he would sit down and try to bond with him because of it.

Then lastly: Katsuki. He already knew Katsuki's story, but now it made sense why he was added to the team. Whether he knew it or not, Aizawa's heart was plainly on his sleeve. He had a soft spot for people who desperately needed a place in the world. Izuku wondered if that's why he ultimately took him in.

They were all sitting around eating lunch. It was a simple meal, sandwiches and soups to combat the cold weather. Conversation buzzed low, until Izuku turned to Katsuki.

"Kacchan, do you want the rest of my soup?" he asked, nudging the half-full bowl toward him.

Katsuki lifted his head. "Sure, but take my bread."

There was a pause. Then, from down the table, Sero frowned and leaned in like he hadn't heard correctly.

"Wait," Sero questioned slowly. He pointed at Izuku. "What did you call him?"

Izuku blinked, confused. "I called him Kacchan?"

The reaction was instant. Aizawa coughed on his drink, barely saving his dignity. Denki's fork clattered to his plate as he doubled over laughing. Sero and Miruko let out a bark of disbelief that trailed into giggles. Monoma smirked like he'd been handed a gift. Even Shinsou perked up, blinking like he had been told something outlandish.

Katsuki scowled at them all, yanking the bowl of soup toward him with more force than necessary.

"Oh, this just keeps getting better and better," Monoma snickered. He lounged back in his chair, full of satisfaction.

"No way," Denki wheezed between laughs. "You actually let him call you that?"

Katsuki shot him a glare sharp enough to draw blood. "Fuck off."

Denki only laughed harder, slapping Sero on the shoulder. "Holy shit! This is like when you meet a vicious, terrifying dog and it's named something like *Muffins*."

"It's nothing like that," Katsuki gritted out, face progressively turning a dangerous shade of red. "Kacchan is perfectly damn normal."

Izuku shrank a little in his seat, cheeks flushing. He hadn't realized the nickname would cause this much chaos.

"Oh my god," Monoma murmured, lips twitching. "Wait. You *like* it."

Katsuki opened his mouth to argue but closed it just as fast.

Denki leaned in, eyes gleaming with wicked amusement. "Do you make him call you that during—"

Katsuki didn't even let him finish. He brandished his spoon like a weapon, voice low and deadly. "One more word and you're eating this, Pikachu."

Denki only threw his head back and howled with laughter.

Miruko grinned, propping her chin on her hand. "I think it's cute! Do you have a pet name for him?"

Silence.

Izuku went pink to the roots of his hair. Katsuki looked like he wanted to dig a hole and bury himself alive.

“It’s Deku, right?” Monoma raised a brow. “Shame. Kacchan is so nice and you’re over here calling him Deku like the ass you are.”

Katsuki didn’t answer. He hunched over his bowl and shoved another spoonful into his mouth.

Aizawa, who had been quietly observing the entire exchange with the amusement of someone witnessing a slow-moving train wreck, narrowed his eyes. He glanced between Izuku and Katsuki closely and noticed the difference in their body language.

“It’s not Deku,” Aizawa said. “Is it?”

Katsuki growled low under his breath. “What I call him is nobody’s fucking business.”

The table cracked open with another wave of laughter. The sound spilled into every corner of the room. Denki was red in the face, clutching his ribs. Sero wiped tears from the corners of his eyes. Even Miruko had to set her drink down, laughing too hard to hold onto it.

Katsuki sat there, pink-cheeked and glowering into his soup like it had personally betrayed him. Beside him, Izuku fidgeted, his own face flushed the same rosy shade.

He hadn’t considered giving Katsuki a nickname would cause such a spectacle. But here they were.

Gradually, everyone eased back into their meals, the laughter softened into little chuckles and quiet teasing under their breath. Izuku tried to bury his face in his sandwich, but the fluttering warmth in his chest betrayed him. Despite the embarrassment, he couldn’t help but smile.

It was different here.

The teasing was light, affectionate, without any of the sharp edges he was used to. This was nothing like Tomura’s family dinners, where the air had always been tense and the conversations careful. Back then, he’d thought those stiff interactions were the best life had to offer because they were better than nothing.

But sitting here, at a table loud with harmony, bumping elbows, and casual chaos, it felt like a real family.

He supposed this is what it was meant to feel like when everyone equally cared for each other.

As they ate, Denki curiously eyed around the cabin.

“So what are we going to do while we’re here?” Denki piped up. “Are we going to sit around for five and a half weeks and do nothing? You didn’t tell us this assignment was going to mean we’re stuck here, Aizawa.”

“I told you to pack for two months,” Aizawa lectured.

Denki groaned and threw his head back. “I thought you were just saying that because Bakugou is unpredictable.”

Miruko huffed. “If you call this situation predictable, I want to know what you consider not.”

“Well, I brought some video games,” Sero offered sheepishly. “I also packed some board games to keep us all occupied.”

“There’s no way in hell I’m playing anything again with firecracker here,” Monoma joked, jutting his chin towards Katsuki. “He’s too weirdly good at games.”

At that, Izuku’s eyes sparked with agreement. He turned to Monoma and nodded quickly. “He is, isn’t he? It’s so strange.”

“Don’t hate the player, hate the game,” Katsuki retorted smugly. He bit into his messy sandwich and smiled fiendishly, earning a couple of disgusted leers at the lack of decorum.

“I actually already planned an itinerary for all of you,” Aizawa interjected. This caused the conversation to halt and all eyes turned towards him. “Well, everyone except Miruko. She’s here because we need extra hands and I need someone sane to talk to.”

“Oh! Exciting!” Denki exclaimed with a wide grin. “What will we be doing? An M-Unit special?”

“Well. After I finish all this paperwork, we’re going to begin to rotate chores, keep your fighting skills sharp, and make sure to go over inventory of guns, bullets, and blades.” Aizawa paused, then smiled slyly. “Oh. And you all will be fixing up my cabin.”

Groans spilled into the air.

Katsuki made a disgusted face. “You’re shitting me.”

“That is child labor,” Sero deadpanned.

“You’re all in your mid twenties,” Aizawa shot back. “And you’re staying here free on my dime. There’s a couple of loose floorboards and someone has to go chop firewood to keep the chimney going. Not to mention there’s a couple of leaky faucets and roof tiles that need re-gluing.”

“Make Bakugou do all of that,” Monoma drawled grumpily. “This is all his fault.”

“Of course your lazy ass would make me do the heavy lifting.” Katsuki shot Monoma a cold glare.

“I can get started on whatever you would like,” Izuku chimed in quietly.

All eyes turned to him.

Everyone, but Katsuki, seemed surprised. Silence weaved through the air. Izuku nervously glanced around, unsure why what he said caused such a stunned reaction. Miruko and

Aizawa exchanged secret glances. Aizawa half way smiled.

“You all should be more like Izuku,” Aizawa said with a hint of humor. “Finally, someone with some manners.”

ᔓᔓᔓ

Over the rest of the week, they all threw themselves into the long, groaning list of chores needed to fix up the cabins.

All except Miruko, who Izuku learned was Aizawa’s equal. She ran a different sector of The Company and was solely here because Katsuki’s voicemails raise so much alarm they thought it might be an all hands on deck assignment. She kicked her feet up and enjoyed soap operas in front of the fireplace while the rest of them got to work.

Izuku, ever polite, was starting to regret his eagerness to help out. Especially when he found himself prying up a full row of stubborn, splintering floorboards. It took hours. Turns out, he had zero carpentry skills, but he made up for it with sheer stubborn effort.

He managed to finish the floors and even cleaned out the chimney to the best of his ability, soot streaked across his face like war paint. Aizawa gave him a long look afterward, humming thoughtfully before offering a rare, almost-surprised nod.

When Izuku patched the roof solo a day later, Aizawa actually tossed him a validating, “Not bad.”

That said, the others weren’t so lucky.

Aizawa was far less impressed with the rest of the agents—most of whom he had repeatedly caught slacking, hiding, or trying to sneak away with the grace of a raccoon into the kitchen. Eventually, he resigned himself to supervising full-time. He hovered like a hawk with a blanket wrapped around his shoulders and a steaming cup of hot coco in his hands.

“Put your back into it, Sero,” he muttered one morning, passing the kitchen where his nephew was locked in a life-or-death struggle with the leaky sink. Water sprayed everywhere, making Sero flail like a man drowning.

“You could at least help me!” Sero protested, shielding his face from the squirting.

Aizawa took a slow, satisfied sip of his drink. “No,” he said flatly. “I don’t think I will.”

It went on like this, until one day they ran out of wood for the fireplace.

“Bakugou,” Aizawa barked. “Go outside and chop the firewood we’ll need for the upcoming week. There’s a long blizzard coming and we’re not going to have a chance to do it tomorrow.”

“Why do I have to do it?” Katsuki grumbled, heavily annoyed. “Shinsou is just as strong.”

“Shinsou didn’t murder five members of Chisaki Kai’s family,” Aizawa replied bluntly.

Begrudgingly, Katsuki got up.

Izuku gave Aizawa a soft smile, which was returned in Aizawa’s very own way.

He and Katsuki threw on their winter jackets, readying themselves. Izuku still wore the plush, olive green coat Nana had gifted him. Katsuki’s coat was newer, a sleek black goose-down lined with faux grey fur around the hood. Aizawa had bought him the coat when he saw the leather jacket was all Katsuki had on him. Aizawa was also kind enough to buy them both new, winter boots. They were matching, darkly colored and completely waterproof to help shield them from the steep snow on the mountain.

As they exited to the back porch, the cold welcomed them by nipping at their noses.

Katsuki strolled over to the pile of wood sitting on the side of the cabin. He adjusted his gloves before picking up the sharp axe and slugging it over his shoulder. He lugged it along as he grabbed for one chunky piece of wood grumpily.

Izuku took a moment to stare. Katsuki with an axe reeked of an intoxicating type of danger.

His husband caught him and smirked. “You really like checking me out while I’m holding a weapon, huh?”

“A little,” Izuku replied with a blush and a grin. “Sorry. Bad habit at this point.”

Katsuki smiled and leaned in. “Nothin’ bad about it.”

He placed a kiss on the corner of Izuku’s mouth. Quick and soft enough to make Izuku’s stomach flip. With that, they stepped out to the chopping block. Katsuki began to set up and immediately got to work. His shoulders flexed, axe swinging down with clean, practiced force. Each log split with a satisfying crack, the rhythm steady and grounding.

Izuku stood nearby, stacking the chopped firewood in neat, uneven piles. They didn’t talk much. They carried on this rhythm of Katsuki chopping and Izuku stacking, without missing a beat. Katsuki glanced at him every so often with a half smirk.

“You know,” Katsuki muttered after the tenth log split clean in half, “You didn’t have to follow me out here. Aizawa made it clear he’s punishing me for being bullheaded.”

Izuku chuckled, brushing a bit of sawdust off his gloves. “I’m always happy to help you out, Kacchan.”

Katsuki huffed. “You’re too nice sometimes.”

“I can’t help it,” Izuku proclaimed, completely unashamed. “Especially when it comes to you.”

That earned him a sharp look. But Katsuki didn’t argue—simply raised the axe again with a smirk tugging at his lips. Izuku gawked a little longer than necessary, warmth pooling behind

his ribs.

After about an hour, the firewood was now piled high. Katsuki chopped more than enough to last the week and then some. He gave a couple more swings for good measure before he stopped completely. With a huff, he wiped his brow with the back of his hand and turned to Izuku, who was placing the last piece of wood on the pile. He rested the axe over his shoulder and leaned all his weight into one hip.

“Y’know. I think you impressed Aizawa this week,” Katsuki praised with a grin.

Izuku paused his stacking. “Really?”

“Yeah.” Katsuki shrugged like it was no big deal, but Izuku saw a tiny glint in his eye. “He gave you a nod and even told you ‘not bad’. It took me years to get that and you got it in less than a month.”

Izuku burst out laughing. “I didn’t realize that was a big deal.”

“Hey,” Katsuki warned, “From the old man? That’s practically a standing ovation.”

Izuku’s chest swelled, breath visible in the cold air. He smiled happily, keening at the validation. He really wanted Aizawa to like him, and he supposed if that meant digging up more floorboards than he would do it for the next month if he had to.

“I’ve been trying to make sure I earn my keep,” Izuku admitted. “Their opinions are important to you, so it’s kind of important to me too. Is that weird? I want them to see that I can be…well adjusted.”

Katsuki didn’t say anything for a moment.

“I think they’re starting to see it,” he reasoned. “Just give it some time, it won’t be fast.”

“Okay,” Izuku replied. He smiled, feeling slightly better.

He barely had time to enjoy the smug smirk spreading across Katsuki’s face when the cabin door creaked open behind them.

“Hope you two are actually chopping wood and not making out,” Monoma called, stepping out and squinting against the sunlight bouncing off the snow. He had a blue scarf looped around his neck and a paper bag under one arm. “It would be a shame if we all froze to death because you two couldn’t pause your lethal domestic bliss for an hour.”

Shinsou followed him, hands stuffed deep in his coat pockets. A neutral scowl was on his lips as his eyes cut to Izuku.

Izuku straightened instinctively.

Katsuki didn’t miss a beat. “You two creeps come out here to supervise?”

Monoma smirked. “Should we?” His eyes flicked between them, and Izuku was suddenly very aware of how close he and Katsuki were standing. “Sounds like you have a guilty conscience.”

“We’re actually heading into town,” Shinsou added, tone clipped. “Blizzard’s coming in hard tomorrow. Gonna stock up on food and other supplies while we can.”

Izuku nodded, and tried to think of a way to be helpful. “Want us to write down anything you might need to get?”

“No,” Shinsou replied without looking at him.

Monoma gave him an unhappy glance. “Ignore his charming personality. We’ve got a list. Just make sure this firewood actually gets inside.”

“Yeah yeah, we got it,” Katsuki huffed, casually readjusting the axe on his shoulder. “You two hurry before the storm blows in.”

“We’ll do our best,” Monoma drawled, beginning to walk away towards the mountain exit. “Go easy on the poor guy, Bakugou.”

Shinsou didn’t bother saying goodbye. However, Izuku caught the brief, mistrustful glance he shot back over his shoulder. Once the two vanished into the trees, Katsuki let out a low snort.

“I give it twenty minutes before they’re arguing about which brand of hot sauce to buy,” he grumbled.

Izuku stifled a laugh, appreciating the joke. But he couldn’t get past the cold look Shinsou gave him before departing. As if Katsuki could practically see his hang up, his husband stepped in front of him and leaned down. He smiled gently in a reassuring way.

“Hey. Ignore Shinsou,” Katsuki advised firmly. “He’s very unwelcoming to newcomers. Hell, he didn’t really warm up to me until the second year we worked together.”

Izuku nodded along. “Do you think it’s because of my background? That I’m too… unpredictable to him?”

“Maybe,” Katsuki sighed. He leaned back up to his full height and paused thoughtfully. “It's probably just him though. His upbringing, wasn’t the best, y’know? It’s hard for him to trust others.”

“What was his upbringing?”

“Him and Monoma grew up in an orphanage together. But out of the two of them, Shinsou was the only one who was there since birth. He bounced around a lot and many of the homes were filled with the worst kind of people. It made him very untrusting because he only saw the ugly side of human nature.”

“But not Monoma?” Izuku questioned.

“Monoma got put in the orphanage older,” Katsuki explained. “Around seven or nine. I can’t remember which. He remembers having parents who loved him before they died in a car crash. And that kind of love sticks with you, even if it’s short-lived. Gives you a little more faith in people, I guess. But don’t let that fool you, Monoma’s not exactly a picnic. That asshole gives me a hard time—he treats me like some sort of barbarian.”

Izuku nodded, appreciating the bit of color that has been added to Shinsou and Monoma.

When the clouds above them blocked out the sun, they both looked up in the sky. There was a thick, dark blanket of grey above them now, spreading out to every inch that the eye could see.

Katsuki sucked at his teeth and motioned with his head back to the door.

“C’mon, let’s hurry and get all the wood inside before it starts coming down.”

ɯɯɯ

Week Two in Winter Paradise

The blizzard came raging, exactly like Aizawa said. It hit the same day their second week in the cabin started.

The windows had vanished beneath a thick veil of white, the overcast was so dense it felt as though the world had been erased beyond the glass.

Outside, the wind howled like restless phantoms. Its voice twisted through the air in long, mournful wails. Each breath the storm took seemed deliberate—an inhale that swelled with quiet menace, followed by an exhale that shuddered through the cabin walls, making the furniture creak and shift. It never jolted hard enough to stir fear, but just enough to remind them it was not safe to step outside.

Izuku tossed another log into the fireplace, nudging it in with the iron poker. Sparks jumped as the flames caught hold, crackling with approval. The fire welcomed the fuel, stretching higher and rewarding the room with warmth.

They were all sitting around the living room watching an old Romeo and Juliet movie. They had gotten to the part where the story culminates tragically with Romeo finding Juliet’s still body. He was grieving over her, holding her in his arms.

As the actors weeped on screen, a couple of sniffles were audible. Everyone’s eyes were glued to the tragedy with a blanket tossed over their bodies. Overall, the cabin ended up being exactly one blanket short, which caused Izuku and Katsuki to share one. Izuku didn’t mind though, and neither did Katsuki.

Izuku wandered back to his place on the couch and Katsuki opened the fuzzy blanket for him.

Instinctively, he curled into Katsuki’s side, letting their legs tangled beneath the thick blanket. Katsuki tugged the edge up over Izuku’s shoulders, then pressed a kiss to his temple without

saying a word.

Izuku smiled and slipped his cold fingers beneath Katsuki's hoodie, earning a soft grunt.

"Your fingers are freezing, nerd," Katsuki hissed.

"Sorry," Izuku whispered back, not really sorry at all.

Katsuki rolled his eyes but pulled him closer. He rested his cheek on Izuku's curls, and happily encased his warm palms over Izuku's appendages.

"My god," Monoma uttered, completely astonished. "It's like watching a dog walk on its hind legs."

Izuku and Katsuki both turned to find every single set of eyes glued to them, not the TV. Aizawa had his eyebrow raised, piqued in interest. Miruko was grinning from under her blanket. Monoma, Sero, and Shinsou were all wearing various expressions that ranged from gaping in disbelief and utter disgust.

Heat crept up Izuku's face as he shrank slightly.

"Keep your eyes on the stupid movie," Katsuki barked.

A ripple of snickers passed through the room, but they obeyed. Everyone turned back to the screen with extremely smug expressions. Still red-faced, Katsuki scowled at no one in particular and yanked Izuku even closer.

This was becoming a frequent occurrence.

Over the last week, Izuku learned Katsuki's coworkers were really not used to seeing him act so softly. They practically balked when they had caught them kissing in the kitchen a couple of days ago.

Which to Izuku, was odd. All he had ever known was soft Katsuki. Gruff? Yes. Blunt? Always. Rude? Without ever missing a day. But Katsuki had always been overwhelmingly kind, deep down. No matter how much he tried to hide it, his gentle side seeped out like a light peeking through a dark cloud.

From the other couch, Sero leaned back with a sly grin. "Does he bark for you too, Izuku?"

Izuku's cheeks went deep pink.

Katsuki didn't even blink. "Only when he asks nicely."

Denki choked on his popcorn.

"If you all can't concentrate on the movie, I can give you more chores to do," Aizawa grumbled.

Everyone immediately protested, Izuku included.

They continued to watch the movie, this time in silence.

As the story began to climb to its climax, Izuku's heart clenched like it always did at this part. It was such a shame to him how easily they could have avoided their doomed fate. If only there had been a little more time for Romeo realize Juliet was still alive.

He watched sadly as Romeo pulled the poison vile from his pocket and pressed it to his lips.

ɯɯɯ

For the later half of the week, Aizawa wanted everyone to go through what to do in the worst case scenario.

"We're going to make our exit strategy now," Aizawa forewarned.

It was said with enough foreboding that a chill climbed down Izuku's spine. He wanted to believe they were safe, tucked away in this mountain, but given how far the influence of the Yakuza stretched—they couldn't be too sure.

Aizawa pulled out a map of the northernmost tip of the country. He sprawled it across the table in the reading room and they all gathered around.

Katsuki's frown was sternly deep. Miruko's eyes were laser sharp. And everyone else was sharing glances, as if they were accepting what was to come.

With careful diligence, Aizawa began to pen several asterisks across the map. Each point was hugging the coastline near where Mount Rausu was.

"I have stationed exactly ten speed boats at various docks nearby," Aizawa explained. "If it comes to the point where we need to get the hell out of here, everyone gets to one of these. No matter what. We will rendezvous in Nemuro." He circled the tiny town that was across the bay. "There's a Company headquarters here where we can recuperate."

Everyone nodded, memorizing the tiny address Aizawa wrote down on the paper.

Aizawa then led them to the backside of the cabin, where the living residences were.

Then he opened the room that he placed Katsuki and Izuku in.

He swiftly lifted his leg, dug his foot in the rug, and kicked it backward. The rug folded on itself, revealing a square hatch embedded in the floor. Its metal handle was rusted, old with age and years.

Aizawa crouched down, gripped it, and hauled the latch open with a grunt.

Beneath it was a concrete staircase. It was steep, narrow, and descended into pitch-black stillness.

"This is a secret safe room," Aizawa said, tone tight. "Inside of it is a secret door to a passageway that'll spit you out in the direction of the ski lift. It's an easy out that could

potentially buy time to flee to safety."

Everyone nodded, but Izuku wasn't sure he liked the way that was phrased.

Why did Aizawa make it sound like the plan was to leave people behind?

They filed down into the hidden room, feet echoing against the stone steps. The air turned colder the farther they went, and the walls closed in like the ribs of a great, sleeping beast.

When Aizawa flicked the lights on, harsh fluorescent beams sputtered to life. The light revealed a stark, windowless bunker. The grey walls were lined with shelves cluttered in dust-coated rifles, pistols, boxes of ammunition, and blades dulled from time. Behind several crates was the steel door to the outside, and a cold draft wandered in from its direction.

"A lot of these guns are old, and haven't been used in years," Aizawa explained as Denki wiped the grime from the barrel of an old shotgun. "We're going to have to go through each one and make sure they work."

Miruko picked up one of the larger blades. Its edge was jagged, dulled by rust and overuse.

"We'll need to sharpen these too," she said, testing the weight in her hand like she already knew what it was capable of.

Aizawa nodded, his expression unreadable. Then he looked at all of them.

"Grab what you can. Blades. Guns. Whatever still works," He instructed firmly. "We're taking full inventory. No room for half-measures anymore."

The room filled with movement, but the silence under them pulsed. A quiet understanding slipped across everyone as they filled their hands with as much as they could. Izuku watched as Katsuki easily picked up a crate or two and saw Denki carefully try to handle several knives.

Guilt ate at him as he saw them all prepare for the battle that was surely inevitable.

ᔓᔓᔓ

They settled in around the living room and kitchen. Various stations were set up to inspect the guns and count the ammo.

Miruko and Katsuki had found sharpening stones for the blades and Aizawa was carefully inspecting the bullets with the help of Shinsou. Izuku, Denki, and Monoma were gathered around on the couch. They had an assembly line of sorting the guns in piles of 'usable' and 'not'.

Sero was at the end, close to Katsuki, double checking if the guns were actually usable.

Izuku thumbed the chamber of the revolver, letting the last shell tumble into the bowl with a metallic clink. He glanced up, and his eyes caught on his husband.

Across the room, Katsuki was hunched over the table. His sleeves were shoved up, showing how his forearms flexed with every slow, deliberate pull of the blade across the whetstone. The scrape of metal echoed, low and rhythmic, like a threat on loop. His jaw was tight and his lips were pressed together in deep concentration. And his eyes were sharp and predatory, never once lifting from the edge he was crafting.

Izuku bit the inside of his cheek when heat crawled up his neck.

“Sooo…is the sex like…crazy?” Denki whispered, mouthing the last word like it was classified.

Izuku nearly dropped the revolver. He whirled to Denki who was giving him a knowing smirk.

“E-Excuse me?” Izuku squeaked, his voice going up an octave.

“You can be honest with me,” Denki said. He wiggled his eyebrows while sliding in closer to Izuku. “I’m not like the others, I’m super chill. I mean, all that years-long enemies-to-lovers tension? That’s gotta lead to some explosive results. High risk, high reward type of stuff, yeah?”

Izuku’s mouth hung open as blush raced across his nape.

“You scoot any closer to him and I’m coming over there,” Katsuki said from across the room, not even glancing up. The blade in his hand screeched against the stone like a warning.

Denki laughed nervously. “Oof, I forgot Bakugou is the jealous type.”

He put his hands up, hiding with humor how he did fear for his life. He put a healthy distance between him and Izuku and politely went back to doing inventory.

“Question,” Sero piped up casually, clearly enjoying the chaos, “What are your last names? Did you guys choose one of the other’s surnames or did you hyphenate?”

“I bet they hyphenated,” Monoma interjected. He reloaded a gun with a swift gesture and raised a brow at Izuku. “Katsuki seems like the type to insist on equal billing.”

“Our last name is Bakugou,” Katsuki replied, shooting Monoma a glare.

“Did he agree to that?” Sero pointed out while checking the trigger of one gun. “You guys did get married drunk, and I can totally imagine you completely went cave man and claimed him as your bride or something.”

“I, uh, actually really like Bakugou as my surname,” Izuku interjected, a touch shy. “It has a nice ring to it.”

Monoma seemed surprised. “You’re okay with it?”

“Yeah,” Izuku then smiled at Katsuki and the gesture was returned tenfold. “I’m happy to carry it.”

There was a beat of silence, as if Izuku's answer was news.

"Speaking of the big M," Miruko interjected suddenly. She pointed directly at the shabby rings on both of their fingers. "Please don't tell me those are what I think they are."

That got Aizawa's attention.

Up until now, he'd been doing his best to ignore the nonsense unfolding around him. But at the mention of rings, his interest piqued. He leaned over to glance at Katsuki's hand, eyes narrowing. Then, without a word, he stood, crossed the room, and gently took Izuku's left hand in his own.

Everyone watched, perplexed, as Aizawa pulled out a pair of reading glasses from his pocket like this was a scheduled appraisal. Izuku froze under the older man's touch, posture straightening as Aizawa peered in with the scrutiny of a jeweler. The lines on his face deepened with disappointment as he studied the battered ring.

Then his gaze shifted to Katsuki, flat and unimpressed.

"Bakugou, I didn't peg you as cheap," he said, voice low and judgmental. "You proposed to this poor boy with a fake ruby? Even with how much I pay you?"

Katsuki spluttered and his cheeks colored red.

"N-No! I'm not fucking cheap, you know that!" Katsuki hissed.

He stood up, and marched over. Defensively, he snatched Izuku's hand away from Aizawa and clasped it tightly, shielding the tiny ring from more scrutiny.

"And there was no proposal," he snipped. "We got these rings quickly at a street vender in Okinawa to keep up the ruse. We didn't exactly have time to take a stroll through Tiffany & Co."

Shinsou raised an eyebrow. "Not even while you were practically on a honeymoon in Biei?"

"I—" Katsuki started. His embarrassment died down when he looked at Izuku. His eyes saddened slightly, as if his thoughts snagged on a particularly uncomfortable realization. He glanced down at Izuku's rusted ring. "No. We didn't…have time."

Izuku fell quiet too.

It always felt like they were trying to out wit Father Time.

Every step of their journey so far was them desperately trying to carve out space for the two of them. But even with their combined strength, they couldn't stop the hands of time from ticking forward.

Katsuki pursed his lips and grumbled something under his breath. He walked back over to the knife sharpening station and sat down. He began grinding his blade with much more vigor, frustrated.

Sero smiled at him apologetically as he tested the trigger of another gun.

Monoma then leaned into Izuku. He whispered, “When you two get settled in your new identities, make sure he buys you a real ring. Don’t let that bastard off so easily. I know for a fact he has several offshore accounts stacked with money because he’s stingy.”

Just as Izuku was about to ask how Monoma knew that—the deafening sound of a gun shot struck.

Everyone in the room jolted, caught off guard. They all whirled around at the sound of Katsuki’s raw, ear piercing scream.

Izuku’s heart stopped.

Blood was pouring out of Katsuki’s thigh steadily. He howled in pain as he flopped back, grabbed his thigh, and curled on the ground.

“What the fuck, Sero?!” Katsuki roared, voice breaking around the pain. His glare was wild, teeth bared. “You *shot* me!”

“Oh my god!” Sero yelled, mortified. He dropped the smoking gun in his hands like it was made of coals. “I-I’m so sorry I thought the safety was on—”

“—I just fucking healed up!” Katsuki screamed loudly. He hissed in agonizing pain as he applied pressure to the wound. “Oh you *sonofabitch*—I’m going to kill you—”

Izuku practically sprinted across the room.

He dropped on his knees to where his husband was. And instantly, he began to apply pressure and cradle him. His hands were shaking as he checked for a shattered bone, praying the bullet hadn’t hit an artery. Izuku’s voice came out with hurried questions, quick and clinical.

“Did it hit the femoral?” Izuku asked hastily. “A-Any numbness?”

“No and no,” Katsuki ground out, each word a growl. His hand began gripping Izuku’s like a vice.

Izuku gripped back as he inspected the wound. “Shit. It’s deep. Did it hit where you were shot before?”

“No.”

Izuku exhaled hard. He didn’t even notice he was holding his breath until it came out shaky.

Then he looked up.

The room had gone silent. Everyone was staring, stunned. Shinsou in particular was gaping hard. It was obvious he was taken back, but he wasn’t the only one. However, the gawking only agitated Izuku this time. This wasn’t the moment for everyone to look at them crazy—Katsuki was hurt.

“Is there a first aid kit here?” Izuku asked Aizawa, ignoring everyone.

“Yeah…” Aizawa replied slowly. “I’ll go get it.”

He turned around and left for the kit. Izuku returned his gaze to his husband and stroked his forehead.

“Are you sure you’re okay?” Izuku asked tenderly.

“I’m fine,” Katsuki grumbled, leaning into the touch. “It’s not the first time one of these imbeciles have shot me.” Katsuki craned his neck to glare at Denki, fierce gaze terrifying down to the bone. “Last time Pikachu shot me in the ass.”

“On accident!” Denki defended quickly. “I was on the field for the first time and got spooked. Bakugou came around the corner looking all grizzly and I thought he was someone from the other side, so I shot.”

Katsuki grumbled at him.

Izuku quietly waited for Aizawa to return. In the meantime, Sero, Katsuki and Denki got into a three way yelling debate that consisted of blaming and deflecting. In the fuss, Izuku stayed focused on making sure the bleeding didn’t get out of control. He patiently kept his hand on the wound, applying pressure until his arm shook while gently brushing Katsuki’s bangs.

As he did this, he missed some of the other looks in the room.

Monoma grew quiet, gazing between the two of them like he had seen a whole new side of Katsuki. Miruko’s lips were pursed to the side and her arms were crossed. She tilted her head in quiet approval while beside her, Shinsou hadn’t moved.

This whole time, Shinsou remained silent.

His eyes were boring into Izuku, like he was a walking contradiction.

ᔓᔓᔓ

They got back to doing inventory once Aizawa returned with the first aid kit. He placed it beside Izuku without a word.

The room was quieter now, heavy with the scent of antiseptic and the distant sound of the wind rumbling. Izuku had laid several towels across the couch, a makeshift barrier to keep blood off the cushions, and Katsuki was stretched out over them. He was tense, pants discarded leaving him only in his boxers and the muscles in his thigh twitched beneath Izuku’s careful hands.

“Ouch,” Katsuki hissed. He jerked back, wincing.

“Sorry, Kacchan,” Izuku muttered. He caressed Katsuki’s thigh lovingly. “I’m trying to be as gentle as possible.”

“It’s okay,” Katsuki grumbled. “Not exactly your fault.”

Katsuki loudly hissed through his teeth as Izuku took the tweezers and carefully worked at the embedded bullet. Every tiny motion was deliberate and measured. Izuku’s hands stayed steady despite the way his throat tightened every time Katsuki winced.

There was a quiet moment where Izuku finally pulled the bullet free, dropping it into a metal bowl with a soft clink. He let out a slow breath, and so did Katsuki. The worst part was over.

He began to suture Katsuki up with delicate care.

“So, is Kacchan strictly between the two of you?” Denki teased. “I would love to call you Kacchan, Bakugou!”

Immediately, Katsuki glowered. He lowered his chin and the shadow from his bangs darkened his eyes.

“Try it and see how fast you lose teeth,” Katsuki hissed.

Denki held his hands up, laughing quietly. “Hey, just asking.”

Izuku shook his head, trying to focus. Gingerly, he threaded the needle through Katsuki’s skin, but he paused once more when his husband jerked in pain.

He took a moment to take the tiny towel by his feet and pat Katsuki’s forehead dry from sweat. His husband’s eyes fluttered shut under the touch, face softening noticeably. Izuku smiled, then handed him the cup of coco he had made for him.

“Is that better?” Izuku asked sweetly.

Katsuki sighed into the mug. “It is.”

“He’s milking it,” Monoma butted in. “He’s only acting like a damn baby to get you to dote on him. On an assignment, I’ve seen him give himself twenty stitches before. Without any numbing, behind a dirty warehouse—and he did it with a fishing line.”

“Shut up,” Katsuki snapped.

He glared across the room at the other blond who shot back an unimpressed look.

“Wait,” Izuku said. He halted and looked at Katsuki sideways. “Is that true?”

Katsuki’s mouth opened. Closed. Then he rolled his eyes and muttered something under his breath.

“Maybe,” he grumbled.

Izuku gaped. “Kacchan, if that’s true then why are you wincing so much? This is barely three stitches.”

Katsuki sighed, lowered the mug, and slowly propped himself up on his elbows. There was a flush to his cheeks, more embarrassed than in pain. And when he finally looked up at Izuku, he fixed him with the most guilty smirk imaginable.

“You’re just so sweet,” Katsuki confessed. “It’s hard to not wanna get an extra taste of it every chance I get.”

Izuku huffed. He playfully punched Katsuki’s shoulder.

“Why do you always have to be such a pain in the ass?” Izuku chuckled.

Katsuki grinned flirtatiously. “But I’m *your* pain in the ass.”

Izuku blushed, and giddiness bubbled up inside of him. As much as he wanted to be mad, he couldn’t. He leaned in naturally and so did Katsuki. They grew close enough to have their noses brush.

“Hey!” Sero shouted. He placed the gun down on the counter and pointed his finger. “Please, no kissing in front of us again! You guys get way too into it. I still haven’t recovered from walking in on you two macking down in the kitchen. Bakugou sucks face like a goddamn animal.”

“S-Sorry!” Izuku stammered, blushing.

He lurched back and quickly returned to work on the sutures. Katsuki groaned and flopped back on the couch. He put his hands behind his head and his flinching stopped all together when Izuku threaded the needle through this time.

Miruko snorted. “Well at least we haven’t had anymore three a.m. incidences,” she said, stretching her arms out. “Only kissing, thank goodness. I was worried that loud moaning was going to be a daily occurrence with the way Bakugou is all over the sweet little green bean.”

Izuku and Katsuki laughed quietly.

“Yeah,” Katsuki muttered with a cocksure smirk. “I’m keeping myself under control. No worries.”

ɯɯɯ

The truth was, Katsuki wasn’t under control—and neither was Izuku.

Every night as soon as the lights went off, their passion bloomed to life. They had simply found a better, more sound proof way of doing it now. And it involved a hand tightly cupped over Izuku’s mouth and the loud, roaring shower.

Izuku moaned as Katsuki hit his prostate with another thrust from the back.

Water had soaked his hair all the way through as he whimpered underneath his husband’s palm. His limbs were shaky, barely holding him up as they kneeled together on the shower

floor. He pushed back as the pace they set picked up and the water from the shower head came pouring down.

Katsuki was grunting in his ear. One hand over his mouth, and the other was possessively wrapped around his waist, holding him still as he fucked him with all his might. Their twin moans were muffled by the sound of the rolling water—and Izuku wondered if everyone thought one of them enjoyed really, really long showers.

Steam clung thick to the walls, and the water pounded steadily. It drowned out everything but the sound of their breathing and the slick rhythm of their bodies colliding. Izuku's cheek pressed to the cool tile, his breath fogging the surface, trembling under the steady weight of Katsuki's body behind him.

He cried out quietly as he arched back, urging his husband on.

"You're so fucking gorgeous," Katsuki groaned into the shell of Izuku's ear, his breath hot and ragged.

He punctuated each word with a deep thrust, and Izuku's arms nearly gave out. Katsuki held him steady with a bruising grip around his waist, dragging him back onto each roll of his hips with expert force.

Izuku's lashes fluttered when warm, ecstasy rolled across his limbs. His mouth opened against the press of Katsuki's hand. He moaned into his palm—desperate and overwhelmed. His back arched, caught in the firestorm of pleasure Katsuki was drawing from him without mercy.

"You like this, huh?" Katsuki rasped. "You like when I shut you up and fuck you?"

Izuku nodded, eyes dazed and half-lidded.

Searing heat swelled in his core as his cock bobbed between his legs. The possessiveness in Katsuki's voice was like a drug. The way his husband spoke through clenched teeth, it was like he was barely holding back. It made the erotic sensation tighter, sharper, and more electric.

Katsuki's rhythm picked up.

His hips snapped forward, relentless now. He pushed deeper, harder, and groaned when Izuku clenched around him. His grip moved to Izuku's jaw, tilting his face back enough so he could see him. He cursed when he caught sight of how blissfully wrecked Izuku was.

"They're all stupid if they thought I could keep my hands off you," Katsuki whispered, breathing hot against Izuku's damp cheek. "I'm always going to make sure my sweet husband is full of cum by the end of the day."

Izuku trembled at the thought. His eyes rolled back and he bit his lip. His whole body trembled under Katsuki's aura, and his fingers slipped down against the tile.

Everything about their love making now was messy and tantalizingly intimate. Katsuki reached around then, fingers wrapping firmly around Izuku's aching length and began stroking in time with his thrusts. He began driving him straight to the edge with no breaks.

Izuku sobbed and three fingers were ungracefully thrusted into his mouth. His soft moan was gagged and saliva coated Katsuki's fingers. His body began to seize up with pleasure as he clamped down even more.

Then with one, two, three direct hits against his sweet spot—Izuku's mind was cut with white noise.

His eyes screwed shut as he came undone. His release painted the tile in front of him. His body went tight, shaking, barely able to stay upright—but Katsuki didn't stop.

His husband grunted low, voice cracking as his rhythm faltered and finally shattered. With a final thrust, Katsuki spilled into him. He brutally buried himself deep and held Izuku close. His lips brushed Izuku's temple as he groaned through his own release. They both panted loudly, and it took a second for Katsuki to remove his fingers.

The only sounds left were the loud shower, their panting, and the soft, wet kiss Katsuki pressed to the back of Izuku's neck.

The water had gone lukewarm and the mist was thinning in the air. Izuku sagged against the cool tile, boneless and trembling, while Katsuki held him up with one arm around his middle. His other hand gently carded through damp curls, slower now, affectionate in a way that was almost jarring after how primal they'd been.

Izuku's lips were swollen and his cheek flushed red where Katsuki's palm had been. His lashes were wet, heavy over his cheeks as he struggled to catch his breath. But he didn't pull away. He never could anyways. He leaned into Katsuki like he always did.

Katsuki kissed the top of his shoulder, grinning against his damp skin.

"You're shaking," he murmured smugly. "Didn't know you were still such a lightweight."

Izuku let out a laugh, still dazed.

"You're such an ass," he breathed, barely able to keep himself upright on his knees.

"Yeah," Katsuki agreed. "But you like it."

Katsuki leaned back, not pulling out, but just enough to look down at Izuku. He stared, letting his gaze roam, taking in every mark he'd left. From this angle, he could see where he and Izuku were still connected and a hungry gleam flickered in his eyes.

Izuku's breath caught high, feeling the cock inside of him swell back to life.

"Kacchan?" He asked quietly. He looked back, eyes half lidded and panting. "Do you want to go another round?"

A wicked grin was tossed his way as his husband pressed forward.

His chest was like a furnace against Izuku's back as he slotted them together, leaving no distance. He ground his hips into Izuku, earning a low, sensitive moan from the both of them.

"Of course I do," Katsuki replied back, tilting Izuku's chin up with two fingers. "Darling, I can go for hours for you."

Izuku's pupils blew wide.



Week Three of Winter Paradise

It was now the third week of their time in the cabin, and Izuku was daring to think they could make it to Nana without a blip. Maybe being this high up in the mountains was so far off the Yakuza's radar that they didn't have a thing to worry about from way up here.

It was nice to think so, honestly.

Izuku was getting used to everyone, and was starting to think he could adjust to a life in this way. Every morning they made breakfast together, and every evening they watched movies or played games.

At some point they all went outside and made snowmen.

Katsuki, of course, had jokes. He made his snowman extra plump in the rear with two round globes on the backside and called it Izuku. Izuku angrily tossed a snowball his way, missed, and then that set off a whole chain of events of them participating in another snow ball fight.

This time, everyone joined in—aiming for Katsuki.

His husband was incensed. He yelled and went on the defensive as he was hunted through the snow restlessly. Loud laughs, sarcastic remarks and joy echoed in the air. Izuku giggled every step of the way, enjoying the chaos that made him feel absolutely normal. He couldn't remember the last time he had this much fun.

They chased Katsuki around the mountain until sunset and then all made snow angels. Even Shinsou had joined in, warming up to Izuku ever so slightly.

Later in the week, Aizawa urged them all to do strength and flexibility training when Sero revealed he pulled a muscle during the snowball fight.

Agility training was light work for Izuku. But it was here everyone could see Sero and Denki were not the best physically out of the group. This revelation made Aizawa suggest sparring matches where they all traded techniques.

They went in twos, mixing, matching and pairing up with each other. However, when it got to him and Katsuki going head to head—it ended up being painfully clear that when put against

each other they gridlocked. But not because of skill, but because it was obvious they were each other's weak points. Izuku pulled his kicks, and Katsuki's punches didn't land as accurately.

It made Aizawa drop his head at a point and mutter, "No wonder you never caught him."

They both blushed when everyone laughed at them.

One evening, after dinner and a few lazy rounds of cards by the fire, the cabin gradually quieted.

Laughter faded into yawns, and one by one, the others peeled off to their rooms. Denki was the last to leave, muttering something about Aizawa's training being harder than prison time before disappearing down the hall.

Izuku lingered in the living room, curling his hands around a still-steaming mug of cocoa Katsuki had made for him. Across the room, his husband was silently gathering the mugs and plates from the evening—still full of that twitchy, restless energy even in the calm.

Izuku watched him for a moment, soaking in the domestic bliss they had been afforded.

The quiet clink of ceramic. The way the firelight played along his jaw. The subtle way Katsuki's shoulders finally began to drop.

Without thinking too hard, Izuku got up and wandered over to the window. The frost had crept up the edges of the glass, curling in delicate fractals.

Katsuki came up beside him a few moments later. He hugged Izuku from behind, kissing the top of his head quietly.

Izuku looked out of the frosted window. It was snowing now, as gentle and steady as stardust.

He leaned against the windowpane, pressing close enough for his breath to bloom in soft clouds across the glass. Below, the world lay drowned in white. An endless, unbroken expanse stretched toward the horizon like the hush after a lullaby. Fresh snow had fallen in thick, velvety sheets, blanketing the mountaintop and smoothing out the jagged edges of the town far beneath them.

From this height, the small town looked like nearly nothing. Tiny rooftops blurred into one another, soft and indistinct. Like little whispers of civilization barely peeking through the snowdrift's embrace.

Izuku took a sip of his cocoa. The heat slid down his throat, rich and sweet, radiating in his chest.

The soft padding of slippers on wood announced Aizawa's approach. He didn't say anything at first either, simply joined them there at the glass. The three of them quietly watched the snow build up on the balcony rail, the eaves, and the crooked trees in the distance.

“The real reason I bought this place wasn’t because it was so isolated,” Aizawa suddenly said.

Both Izuku and Katsuki turned, surprised at the sudden admission. From what Izuku could gather within the last three weeks, this was rare. Aizawa didn’t open up and he didn’t really talk about his past.

“Then what for?” Katsuki asked.

“I bought it because my wife liked it here,” Aizawa whispered.

A solemn expression clouded Katsuki’s eyes.

Aizawa shrugged, not taking his gaze off the tiny houses below. “This place used to be a seasonal rental spot. We would come up here all the time during the winter and…relax. I bought the property because I like being reminded of those times.”

“You’re more sentimental than you lead on,” Katsuki replied quietly. “Sounds like it was a nice time.”

“It was.” Aizawa smiled at Katsuki like he was seeing someone else. “The reason she loved it so much was because you could hear the orchestra down in town from on the balcony. Me, her and our son would go outside and listen to the orchestra play for hours.”

“Really?” Izuku asked. “You can hear it from all the way up here?”

“Mhm,” Aizawa hummed. He leaned against the window. “The orchestra here plays their concerts on speakers for the town. The sound waves echo off the mountain side and it carries. It’s a weird miracle of physics.”

They both studied Aizawa who was still looking at the town. He then exhaled deeply, like he was pulling himself out of a distant memory. He tilted his head to the balcony.

“Go on,” Aizawa urged. “Enjoy the view.”

He turned then, leaving them alone.

Izuku’s gaze tethered to Aizawa’s back, watching him walk away around the corner. There was a visible sadness in every step he took. Like his feet were shackled by invisible weights. Izuku frowned apprehensively. He knew that kind of walk. It was the kind of gait one did when there were ghosts heavily sitting on one’s shoulders.

“He’s married?” Izuku whispered.

“Widowed,” Katsuki corrected quietly. “His wife and son were murdered some time ago. He doesn’t talk about it, but that is whose photographs are on the walls around here. It’s a topic none of us ever discuss—and it’s off the table to bring up.”

Hundreds of burning questions came tumbling forward.

Izuku wanted to blurt out each one, but he kept his lips shut out of respect. He didn't want to accidentally pry for more information and cross the line into gossipy territory.

With a tender smile Katsuki began to slide open the balcony door.

He stepped out into the cold, and Izuku followed. It was slightly warmer today, and their sweaters were able to shield against the biting winds well enough. Izuku hugged his mug with both of his hands as they walked all the way out on the balcony. The floorboards creaked with each step as they settled in, leaning over the rail.

Then came the music. It was soft, almost imperceptible at first.

Izuku's lips curved into a smile as the gentle strains of classical music floated through the crisp air. The cello murmured in low, mournful tones. Violins lifted above it, delicate and soaring, like the wind skimming over treetops. And then the flute: a flicker of silver, playful and fleeting. It wove in and out of the harmony, dancing along the edges of the melody with effortless grace.

"Wow," Katsuki exclaimed, scoffing in disbelief. "I can't believe it. You really can hear it."

"It's beautiful."

Izuku hummed, low and content, as the tune continued. Their shoulders pressed together gently, and warmth was politely exchanged. They stayed there, together, listening to the gentle rise and fall of the faint music. Izuku closed his eyes as the wind swept through his hair. He pictured this is how Aizawa must've felt, all those years ago. What lovely moments he and his wife must have shared.

He opened his eyes to find his husband contemplatively gazing down at the ring on his finger. Katsuki pursed his lips as he reached over to trace the small, faux ruby on Izuku's hand.

"They are looking a little rough, aren't they?" Katsuki muttered.

"Trekking through the snow probably didn't help," Izuku added.

"Yeah," Katsuki chuckled. "They look like shit now."

"Well. They weren't meant to last forever. They were only decoy rings for the assignment."

Izuku held his ring up to the light. It caught nicely against the sun and contrasted the snow like a lovely pop of red. He smiled at it, thinking about all the rings had endured.

"I didn't expect for them to gain so much sentimental value," Izuku mused.

Katsuki didn't respond right away. He let silence trickle in as he shifted his gaze up to meet Izuku's.

"Do you have a dream wedding ring?" Katsuki asked.

Izuku was taken aback. He blinked hard in surprise, not expecting such a question.

Blush began to rise from his neck and colored his cheeks a pretty pink. He laughed as he thought back on all the hopeless romantic day dreams he used to have. It all seemed so silly now. Especially given how his only wish was for them to get to safety.

“Ha, I do,” Izuku replied. He scratched his blushing cheek timidly. “Or I did. You know me, hopeless romantic. B-But what my ring looks like and all that doesn’t matter to me anymore. I’m okay with anything as long as you’re my person at the end of the day.”

Katsuki huffed and shook his head. “But if you could have your dream ring what would it be?”

Izuku pressed his lips in a thin, thoughtful line. It didn’t take much for his romantic tendencies to come rushing forward.

Well. Old habits die hard, he supposed.

“I’ve always adored ‘eternity’ wedding bands,” Izuku answered truthfully. “The concept and look of them is very romantic to me. The way they loop endlessly with diamonds, or whichever gemstone, all the way around. It feels like they truly represent love instead of one, big giant rock. Eternity like infinity. The love just…keeps going around and around. Never ending.”

He smiled at his husband, who smiled back at him.

“I would love an eternity wedding band made of rubies,” Izuku whispered.

He paused for a moment, and gazed deep into Katsuki’s eyes. Up close, Izuku could see the different hues that were scattered around. He tilted his head when he gazed at the lovely bit of orange hugging Katsuki’s pupils.

“…And your dream wedding?” Katsuki questioned.

Izuku shrugged.

“Small. Very personal with a few people and the person I love.” He grinned thinking about it. “I’ve always loved the idea of a wedding on the roof of the tallest skyscraper at night. The city and ocean in the background stretching on and on like the eternity bands…Maybe we’re both dressed in tuxedos with hand made flower crowns.”

He could picture it. A perfect sunset wedding on top of the tallest building where the oranges and purples on the sky bled on the glass and reflected all over.

“How about you, Kacchan? Any romantic ideas floating around up in there?”

“I never gave it thought,” Katsuki confessed. “But I think I would like an eternity band too. One made of emeralds preferably.”

Izuku smiled as their hands intertwined. They stared at each other for a gentle, prolonged moment. When there was only silence, the orchestra could be faintly heard in the background.

A new melody began to play.

Then he heard it. Three specific notes from a violin that made his heart stop on the spot.

Izuku paused. So did Katsuki.

In unison, their heads turned to stare over the horizon down at the tiny town below. Izuku strained his hearing when he knew exactly what the song was. But surely, he was mistaken. However when the next few notes came, they chimed together in an unmistakable manner.

The violins mixed with the viola and the tempo winded around like golden thread into the air. It dazzled and shone, captivating both of their attention like it always did.

Immediately, Izuku thought he must've been hallucinating. He thought this as his eyes grew wider and wider. But when Katsuki's eyes stretched in the same manner he knew that the impossible was happening.

His heartbeat sped up at the same time the viola did.

"Is…" Katsuki whispered, barely breathing, "Is that—"

Izuku finished for him, in utter disbelief.

"The Dance Of The Love Birds?"

Chapter End Notes

I hope you guys liked the chapter! :^) Next chapter is a /very/ special chapter and the last Izuku POV chapter for a couple chapters. After that, we'll be flipping back to Katsuki after so long. It made me a bit emotional bc it has been such a ride :')

Thank you so much for reading!! <3 Please let me know what you think below ❤️

Chapter 37: Staccato

Chapter Summary

Staccato (Stylistic Indication) — Separated

Chapter Notes

Helloooo! Ultra early update because I'm in a silly goofy mood and Luna also is. :') Big thank you to her, the LOML, for betaing like always! Without any further delay, please enjoy this very special chapter!

Warnings: Angst and Violence

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 37 — Staccato

.

.

.

It couldn’t be.

But it was.

As clear as the sky above, they were listening to the melody of their childhood.

Note for note it was the same. But now, instead of only the violin, a new instrument was woven in and out to elevate it: the viola. The two strings twirled around each other like lovers.

The violin leapt, tender and yearning. Then the viola grounded it, rich and solemn. Their dialogue was an enchanting yet precarious conversation without words. Much like a dance performed at the edge of a cliff where each step could mean the fall off the deep end further into the abyss of their devotion.

As the melody spun, the world around them faded.

They found themselves transported back to that winter in Tokyo. Together they were once again in front of the statue of the broken angel, smiling. Every low note reminded them how back then, it was both simpler and so much more fragile. And each high note felt like it was drawn directly into their skin.

And then, the song began its slow, inevitable descent. The pitch floated gently to the ground like a feather. And when it landed, so did the final note. The rift faded into silence and neither of them moved, both too stunned even to breathe.

Izuku's eyes stung from how long he had forgotten to blink.

"…Did I hallucinate that?" Katsuki asked, voice hoarse and dry.

"No," Izuku replied, breathless. He blinked rapidly, shook his head and rubbed his eyes.

"Did *we* fucking hallucinate that?" Katsuki then quickly examined Izuku's mug of cocoa. "Were we slipped shrooms by that damn Denki—"

"—Kacchan, that was real."

Izuku tore his eyes away from the town below to his husband. They stared at each other, completely perplexed.

"How is that possible?" Katsuki whispered.

"Maybe someone else heard the song?" Izuku replied, trying his best to come up with an answer.

"Yeah," Katsuki replied. He nodded slowly. "He could've played it for other people."

Izuku thought maybe that answer was the best. But realistically, it wasn't.

They were with the violinist from start to finish when he was composing that song. Sure, the version the looney man had before their input was similar—but that year they all spent together shaped the song in such a unique way. What they started with was nowhere near what they ended with.

And what they just heard was the exact, final product.

"But you have his violin," Katsuki suddenly said. He glanced wearily at the town below. "You said he gave it to you, right? How could he play this version for other people without his violin?"

Izuku's brows pulled together. "Maybe he bought another?"

"With what money?" Katsuki countered. "He was homeless like I was."

"After you left, I had given him all the money I saved up for us to go to Okinawa."

Katsuki paused, but then so did Izuku.

“But it wasn’t enough to buy another violin,” Izuku whispered, disproving himself.

He whirled around, and tried to think as hard as he could. They both stole one more glance at the town and waited. They waited and waited but no more music came.

When the wind blew a little too hard, Katsuki was the first to move. He pushed away from the railing and walked back inside. Izuku followed him closely and they both wordlessly closed the balcony door and sat on the couch. They didn’t exchange any words, simply stared at the fireplace in total silence.

There was one more, far fetched explanation, which neither of them dared to say out loud.

“How’d you like it?” Aizawa suddenly asked.

They both turned their heads to see Aizawa on the other side of the living room. He was sitting in the large brown reading chair, holding a book. He was smiling at them, oblivious to their confusion.

Izuku blinked while Katsuki cleared his throat and straightened out his back.

“We…” Katsuki started and trailed off. “…We really liked it.”

Aizawa frowned. “Are you sure? You look like you’ve seen a ghost.”

Izuku forced a smile. “We did like it,” he reassured. “It was magical. Thank you for telling us about it.”

At this, Aizawa relaxed and gave a lopsided grin. “I had a feeling you two would enjoy it. It’s a very romantic time. Makes the impossible seem possible.”

“Is there a website or something for the orchestra?” Katsuki quickly asked. “Like can we check out who is scheduled to play or the name of the songs?”

Aizawa shook his head.

“Unfortunately, they’re old school,” he explained. “The town below is pretty rural given its mountain location. You have to go to Will Call to look at the set list and purchase tickets.”

Katsuki frowned. “You mean we would have to go in person?”

“Yes,” Aizawa replied slowly. He squinted at them suspiciously. “Is something the matter?”

“We heard a song we recognized from a long time ago,” Izuku explained. “It’s silly but we knew the homeless street performer who created it. So it’s bizarre to hear it played by a real orchestra.”

At that, Aizawa grew intrigued. “What’s the song?”

They awkwardly shifted on the couch and glimpsed at each other. Izuku started humming first, and then Katsuki followed. Together, off pitch, they tried to mimic the melody to the

best of their abilities. They shaped around each other like they were the violin and viola.

“Ah.” Aizawa raised his brows and nodded. “Yeah. I’ve heard that play from the town a couple times the last two years.”

Both Izuku and Katsuki sat up right.

“Really?” Izuku asked, full of wonder.

“Did you ever go see it in person?” Katsuki also asked at the same time.

“No,” Aizawa replied. “It’s a beautiful melody though. The venue down there has a lot of concerts from new Neo-Classical hits. I think they do tours from select composers.”

Izuku and Katsuki shared a look.

“Crazy coincidence though,” Aizawa mused. “That’s very neat that you knew who made the song. Do you know their name?”

“No,” Katsuki answered, slightly in a grumble. “We, uh, never asked.”

Aizawa shook his head. “Rude. Even as a child,” he sighed heavily. “Well. Maybe you’ll get to hear it again before it’s time to go.”

Izuku offered a faint smile, but his mind was already drifting.

Aizawa began lecturing Katsuki on the importance of always asking people’s names. After that, the conversation settled into a quiet lull. They all lingered there a moment longer, listening to the faint hum of the wind outside.

Eventually, Aizawa stood. He stretched with a soft grunt, and muttered something about going to find the other ‘headaches’ wandering around his property to make sure no one died.

After that, they continued about their day. But Izuku’s mind was stuck. It was as if he was caught on a branch of his memory. No matter how much he tugged and pulled, he stayed entangled in the eeriness that occurred.

“Wow,” Katsuki muttered, still astonished after dinner. Then he smiled at Izuku and took his hand. “What a fuckin’ coincidence, right?”

“Yeah,” Izuku agreed with a light laugh. “How crazy.”

They went to bed that night, chalking up the incident as an insane fluke. Katsuki closed his eyes and reeled him in tight. But Izuku stayed awake in his arms. He intently listened for any semblance of a violin again but found nothing.

That night, Izuku stayed awake for hours looking at the frosted window in their room.

ᔓᔓᔓ

The next day slipped by in a quiet shuffle.

Denki and Sero remained their usual bright, chaotic selves. They were constant sparks of humor that helped mask the undercurrent of tension that lingered beneath the surface. Miruko and Aizawa kept things running smoothly, balancing their distinct brands of discipline and force, while Shinsou and Monoma mostly kept to themselves.

Katsuki, meanwhile, rarely left Izuku's side. Neither of them mentioned the melody again, and The Dance of the Love Birds did not return to haunt their ears.

By the second day, Katsuki had managed to push the entire thing aside. He dismissed it as some bizarre blip. One of those strange, meaningless intersections of memory and chance that occasionally stumbled into their lives.

But Izuku couldn't.

The tune looped in his head like a thread he couldn't stop tugging on. His curiosity gnawed at him in a way that made it hard to focus on anything else. It was a familiar kind of obsession. The kind that had followed him his entire life, and no matter how much he tried to ignore it, he simply couldn't let it go.

It was on the third night, as the two of them lay curled in bed beneath the thick comforter, that he finally spoke the thought aloud.

"I think we should go to the orchestra," Izuku whispered, keeping his voice cautious. "Only for a little bit, if only to see who was playing the song."

Katsuki shifted beside him, the mattress dipping slightly as he propped himself up on one elbow. His brows furrowed with concern. Izuku rolled over to face him, meeting his gaze head-on.

"Is it really that important?" Katsuki asked after a moment, voice low. "I get it. I do, but…" He exhaled slowly, eyes heavy with thought. "I don't want to risk setting anything off. We've managed to stay off the radar this long. I'd rather not give the Yakuza another opening."

Izuku's fingers moved absentmindedly against Katsuki's arm, tracing invisible hearts while his thoughts tumbled about.

"I guess it's not that important," Izuku mumbled. "It's just…I don't know why, but I feel like we have to close the loop. Especially if we're not coming back to Japan." He hesitated. Then added, almost to himself, "What if it's the violinist?"

Katsuki grew sad. "I think he might be dead by now, Izuku. He was pretty damn old and frail."

"I know," Izuku replied quietly, his fingers still moving. "But…I guess I want to see who else knows our song."

Katsuki let out a reluctant huff of laughter, shaking his head.

“Our song, huh?” Katsuki parroted lightly.

“Yeah, it’s *our* song,” Izuku smiled lovingly at his husband who returned the gesture equally. “Is that weird to say? I’ve always thought of that melody as our melody. It feels weird to have it out there and not know who else is playing it.”

Katsuki stared at him for a long moment. Then exhaled a deep, steady breath and laid back down beside him. One hand reached out to brush gently through Izuku’s hair, then traced down along his cheek and neck in one long, thoughtful sweep.

Izuku’s eyes fluttered closed at the touch, and when they reopened, Katsuki was gazing at him like he was a million stars. The fond curve of his lips pushed warmth into Izuku’s heart.

“Okay. You have a point,” Katsuki said. “In the morning, I’ll talk with Aizawa and see if there’s any leeway. If he says it’s safe to go, then we’ll go check it out.”

Izuku’s face lit up with gratitude, and he leaned in without hesitation, beaming.

“Thank you, Kacchan.”

“Anything for you, darling,” Katsuki whispered, soft and sure.

He kissed Izuku’s forehead, and together they sank into the quiet comfort of sleep.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Surprisingly, the next morning over breakfast Aizawa seemed pretty open to their plans about the orchestra.

“We’ve already been down to town a couple of times for supplies,” Aizawa explained, gesturing to Monoma, Shinsou and Miruko. Each one of them shrugged and nodded their heads. “It’s a pretty secluded town. If the Yakuza were searching there, they would have searched up here too by now.”

“I agree,” Shinsou added, much to Izuku’s surprise. “Doesn’t seem to be much down there besides elderly people. It’s pretty closed off.”

Katsuki and Izuku both perked up, sparks of hope igniting in their expressions. Katsuki graced everyone with a rare, softened smile while Izuku grinned like sunlight across his face.

A quiet thrill coiled in Izuku’s stomach, tightening into knots of anticipation. He pictured the violin and viola once more, their voices twinning in that bittersweet harmony, playing their song. He was excited to figure out what was going on down there and if maybe them hearing that song really was a fluke.

“How about we go at the end of the week then?” Katsuki proposed. He now nervously fiddled with his fingers and bit his lip. “I think that would be a perfect time to go.”

Suddenly, Katsuki’s leg began to bounce beneath the table.

It was a restless motion that immediately caught Izuku's attention. It was startlingly rare for Katsuki to show any outward signs of anxiety, and the unprompted fidgeting set off quiet alarms in Izuku's head.

"Why the end of the week?" Aizawa asked, one brow arching as his eyes flicked toward Katsuki's hands. Aizawa, much like Izuku, didn't miss the subtle tension. "It's not like we've got much going on here besides slowly driving each other insane."

Katsuki stiffened. "I, uh, wanted to ask you a favor," he muttered. His gaze shuffled over the others at the table. Color slowly crept across his cheeks as he cleared his throat. He looked distinctly uncomfortable. "Privately. After breakfast."

Denki groaned, dragging out the sound with exaggerated offense.

"Aww, come on, Bakugou," he whined, flashing a toothy grin that bordered on mischievous. "We're all basically family at this point. Whatever it is, spit it out!"

"I said privately, dipshit," Katsuki snapped, voice sharp with embarrassment.

A collective sigh circled the table. Miruko shook her head into her coffee and Monoma rolled his eyes.

Aizawa exhaled and nodded. "Alright. We'll talk after everyone's eaten. Try not to explode in the meantime, Bakugou."

The conversation shifted after that as breakfast carried on. Denki cracked jokes and Miruko poked fun at Monoma's fastidious table manners. But despite the easy atmosphere, Izuku couldn't shake the way Katsuki's thumb kept rubbing slow, anxious circles against his coffee mug. Nor the subtle flicks of his eyes toward him whenever the conversation lulled.

Izuku considered pressing him under the table, maybe nudging his foot as a silent prod, but decided against it. He knew that look on Katsuki's face: it was the one he wore when he had already made up his mind.

So, instead, Izuku sat quietly beside him, finishing the last of his toast.

Everyone eventually trickled out of the kitchen. Their chairs scraped backwards and their footsteps echoed down the hall. Izuku lingered, uncertain whether 'privately' included him or not. Katsuki caught his hesitation and gave him a soft, almost sheepish smile. Then he tipped his chin slightly toward the door in a silent cue.

"That means you too, nerd."

There was his answer.

Izuku sighed through his nose and rose from his seat, casting one last curious glance at his husband.

He didn't like being left out of things, especially when Katsuki was involved. But he didn't push. With a small pout tugging at his lips, he turned on his heel and went to find Denki.

Who, if history was any indication, was probably already neck-deep in some harmless chaos.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Later that night, Izuku decided to follow up.

They were alone in their room, and the quietness of the cabin breathed with the wind. Their room was dim, lit only by the soft glow of a bedside lamp. Izuku nestled into Katsuki's side, their legs tangled beneath the blankets.

"What was that all about at breakfast?" Izuku asked, his voice soft and teasing.

Katsuki smirked, that little flicker of teasing lighting up his eyes.

"Nothing you need to worry your darling head about," Katsuki laughed.

Izuku pouted, pulling back enough to meet his gaze. "You're keeping a secret from me?"

For a heartbeat, Katsuki didn't answer. His expression softened and the corners of his mouth twitched.

"Just trust me," Katsuki murmured, voice lower now. "You'll find out soon enough."

"Okay, fine," Izuku huffed. He decided to let it go. "I trust you."

Katsuki's hand found his cheek. The rough palm cradled him with the kindness his husband reserved only for them. Katsuki then leaned in and kissed him slowly. Izuku closed his eyes and melted into his husband.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Third Week in Winter Paradise

By the end of the week, a fresh wave of jitters settled in Izuku's chest.

Katsuki had been acting strange all week. Almost, nervous? Which was very peculiar for his husband.

However, it wasn't only him.

Aizawa and Miruko were also acting odd. The two older agents smiled at him and Miruko frequently ruffled his hair in a more affectionate way. Not only that, Izuku had even caught Monoma weirdly sneaking around. The sarcastic blond was usually not the secretive type. But he made sure to always steer Izuku away from the reading room whenever he wandered up to the second floor.

It was all stacking up to be strange.

He fidgeted while they dressed for the orchestra. Their clothes were simple and warm. Nothing elegant, but Aizawa had assured them no one at the venue would care.

Izuku pulled on a pale-blue sweater, soft against his skin, and some worn jeans. Katsuki chose a deep crimson turtle neck and paired it with black pants. They wrapped scarves around each other's necks in quiet coordination that held playful chuckles. Katsuki lingered as he adjusted Izuku's scarf, making sure to tuck him in tight.

"Don't want you getting sick," Katsuki teased with a small smirk. "Not that I exactly mind taking care of you now, but just in case. Let's keep you safe."

There was a hint of humor in his voice, but Izuku sensed apprehension as well. Maybe it was tension about leaving the cabin. Or maybe it had to do with whatever he'd discussed with Aizawa earlier in the week.

As they headed out, Shinsou, Denki and Sero hung back.

Aizawa instructed them to, just in case someone came knocking in the worst possible way. As a precaution, Aizawa also gave everyone encrypted closed network cellphones that worked within close range. A fancier term for walkie talkie Izuku learned.

They made their journey down the mountain trail, snow crunching under all their feet. Izuku's nerves prickled the whole way. It was a longer journey than he thought. But at the base of the long slope, nestled quietly into the trees, sat the ski lift. It wasn't the chairlift he'd imagined, but a cable car—large, rounded, and painted a muted blue that almost vanished into the winter sky.

Next to it stood the control station. It was a small shack with a lever and a few simple buttons. Aizawa stepped up and flipped the main switch. The lift groaned to life, metal cables creaking. The control station then hummed like it had just woken from a long sleep.

The doors of the cable car yawned open with a hydraulic sigh. Izuku stepped in first, boots clinking softly against the metal floor. Katsuki followed, brushing his hand against Izuku's lower back in a subtle, protective gesture before settling beside him on the bench. Aizawa, Miruko, and Monoma filed in after them, settling across the car.

Miruko whistled low as she looked out through the curved glass. "Damn. This view will never get old."

Aizawa stood near the back, arms folded.

The doors slid shut behind them. And with a low mechanical grunt, the cable car lifted off the platform and drifted into the air. The world was now beneath their feet. Snow-draped trees, narrow winding paths, and the faint silhouette of the cabin above, all grew steadily smaller and smaller as they drifted off.

Izuku pressed a hand to the window, eyes wide with wonder.

The forest stretched endlessly below, an expanse of white pines and leafless branches. The snow was a mix of silver and gold, painted from the soft afternoon light. Beams of sun peeked through the clouds, casting long streaks of light all over the mountainside. And even from up here, Izuku could see a small river. It curled through the valley like a frozen ribbon, glinting in the distance.

“It’s beautiful,” Izuku murmured in utter awe.

A beat of silence passed behind him before Katsuki answered.

“You’re beautiful,” his husband whispered gently and very close.

Izuku turned his head, cheeks dusting with blush. He caught Katsuki watching him instead of looking out of the window like everyone else. Shyness crept in and Izuku awkwardly laughed, rubbing his neck. He glanced at all the other people and saw Miruko smile and avert her gaze while Monoma stifled a laugh and turned his attention to the window.

“You’re being weird, Kacchan,” Izuku replied with a tiny smile.

“Tch.” Katsuki affectionately rolled his eyes. “Can’t I say something nice to my husband without getting accused of being weird?”

“Not when you’ve been acting all mysterious,” Izuku laughed, nudging Katsuki’s knee with his own. “You’ve been quiet since we left the cabin. Not to mention super secretive the last few days.”

Katsuki shrugged. “I think you like when I am all mysterious. I can see you blush.”

“God,” Monoma muttered from his corner, “Do you two have an off switch, or are you in an endless honeymoon stage?”

Miruko grinned and elbowed Monoma. “Hey. Let them have their moment—”

Suddenly, the cable car jolted without warning.

A giant shudder rattled through the floor, followed by a sharp, metallic clank that echoed through the chamber like a warning bell as if something caught. The air snapped taut with gasps and muttered curses. Everyone’s shoulders stiffened, eyes going wide as the whole cart rocked like a deadly pendulum.

Izuku’s breath caught as the car nearly flew sideways, throwing everyone’s weight off balance. His shoulder slammed into Katsuki’s chest as his whole body slid across the seat. He tried to scramble for purchase and quickly Katsuki’s arms wrapped around him as their bodies slid.

“Shit,” Monoma hissed, half-rising from his seat, one hand gripping the railing.

Aizawa didn’t move from where he stood. He swayed expertly with the sudden tilt and his sharp eyes were already sweeping across the windows. Miruko planted a hand against the wall, feet spread, and clenched her jaw tight.

Slowly, the rocking subsided and a loud, metal groan spilled into the air.

Izuku pulled in a breath and straightened, pulse racing in his throat. His eyes flicked to the others, then to the door, then finally up—searching for any sign of failure.

The cable car groaned once more. Then, gradually, it lurched back into motion. It eased on, smooth and unbothered like nothing had happened.

The silence that followed was thick with unease.

Everyone turned to Aizawa, who was the only one who didn't seem alarmed.

"Small snag," Aizawa explained evenly. "Sometimes it catches, but only rarely. The line's old, but still solid."

"And you didn't think to *warn* any of us?!" Miruko hissed, shaking her head. "You need to get that fixed before it breaks one day!"

Izuku let out a long, shaky breath. He turned his head toward Katsuki who had him tightly in a vice grip. His husband groaned with a long exhale as well and leaned back against the seat. His arms pooled around Izuku's waist as he shook his head.

"What the hell, old man?" Katsuki questioned unhappily. He frowned hard. "That's going to get someone killed."

"You all will be fine," Aizawa curtly grumbled.

Izuku huffed a quiet, nervous laugh, more out of exhaustion than amusement. The cold air that crept in through the cracks of the windows felt sharper now, like the mountain was reminding them exactly how high up they were.

The car continued its descent with a low, mechanical whirl, swaying gently on the line.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When they finally arrived at the orchestra, Izuku was captivated by the architecture.

The building rose out of the snow like a glowing ember in the frostbitten landscape. Its wide arched windows shimmered with condensation. A golden light spilled out into the icy afternoon sky like music given form.

Even from the outside, the soft strains of string instruments swirled into the air. Every note was like a gentle hum that wrapped around Izuku's bones and warmed him from the inside out.

Izuku's eyes scanned the crowd. It was small. Mostly made of elderly folks who were all bundled in thick coats and scarves. Their conversations were gentle and curious, like people who were waiting for a joyous ritual to begin.

Izuku tucked closer to Katsuki, whose hand was warm against the small of his back. Their little group of five stood out in the quiet shuffle of anticipation.

As they stepped through the grand double doors, Izuku felt as though they were being swallowed whole into the belly of a beast.

The lobby stretched wide with polished marble floors, a plush red carpet unraveling like a ribbon beckoning them forward. In the center stood a statue of a golden angel.

When they walked close to her, Izuku took a moment to gaze up. Her wings were spread wide in a silent cry of triumph and in her hands was a harp. At her feet were rows of white roses laid out like a halo.

“It’s gorgeous here,” Miruko said, awe-struck.

“They do a good job at up-keep,” Aizawa agreed.

Izuku kept staring at the angel. He studied how her face was serene and blissful.

They each bought their tickets at the old-fashioned booth that was lined in brass. The ticket itself was a simple white with black ink, but Izuku couldn’t help but study it. In particular, he couldn’t help but memorize the name on the ticket.

“Fated Strings: The Twin Stars Concert Series”

Composer: Souta, Amane

Izuku’s inner child hoped this was who he thought it was.

They all filed into the auditorium for the show.

The room was breathtaking. Rows upon rows of red velvet seats stretched out in perfect symmetry in front of them. Every seat was trimmed with gold that shimmered under the delicate overhead lights. The stage was small, intimate. It was wooden and bare except for two simple chairs placed at its center, angled toward one another like old friends preparing to talk.

Izuku and Katsuki took their seats in the front row alongside Aizawa, Miruko, and Monoma. Everyone around them hummed with gentle excitement.

“They say the composer rose to fame only recently,” Izuku overheard an older woman whisper behind them. “Unusual for someone our age to break through now.”

“Definitely,” another replied. “But his music—it speaks like it’s been waiting to be heard all his life.”

Izuku glanced at Katsuki, who looked equally intrigued. Without a word, Katsuki reached out and laced their fingers together.

Then the lights began to dim.

The hum of voices faded into silence. The air thickened, charged with quiet anticipation. And in that final moment before the performance began, Katsuki looked at him like he was the only thing that mattered in the world.

Izuku smiled. He squeezed Katsuki's hand, heart full.

Then, the audience clapped loudly when a small woman walked out on stage. She had skin similar to Miruko's and big, brown eyes. Her hair was neatly pulled back into a bun with thick black glasses perched on her nose. She straightened out her blazer as she gestured warmly out to the crowd in front of her.

"Hello everyone!" She announced. Her voice boomed off every corner of the room. "I welcome you to the final act! Thank you all so much for sticking around. We have saved the very best performance for you. He is a new composer on the scene and his masterpiece has been sweeping the country. You all know him, Souta Amane."

She took a step back and bowed low. "Please, give him a warm welcome!"

She walked off and two new women walked on. Both were stoic, and a regal air radiated off of them. They were dressed in classic all black ballroom gowns, and were holding the violin and viola respectively. They each took a seat and faced each other, painted in nothing but professionalism. A small smile slipped on their lips.

Then, out walked the one person Izuku never thought he'd see again.

Both Izuku and Katsuki stopped breathing. Their hands tightened.

"Hello music lovers," Souta greeted.

Everyone roared, clapping and cheering.

Izuku couldn't believe it.

His face was the same. His pose was too. Even his voice was laced with that comforting, mischief and magic. However, his body was visibly thinner. He was now older, walking with a limp, but donned in fresh, clean clothes. The hunch in his back was steeper and his wild white hair was neatly combed into a bun for the first time.

He smiled delicately at everyone with stars dancing across his eyes.

"I want to personally thank you all for coming out tonight," Souta spoke. He grinned gratefully at everyone, his eyes never lingering too long in one place. "I know many of you have traveled far to come hear my humble concert pieces. And for that I am more than thankful. I have composed a lovely hour-long session for you, about two twin stars falling from the sky in tandem. It's a love story, at its core. But it is also my vehicle to express my calling. And all I have ever wanted was to share my calling with the world."

He took a large gulp of breath and straightened his back the best he could.

“My calling is that I want to create something beautiful,” Souta repeated those same words he uttered to them years ago. “Something that would never leave someone. I want it to imprint on their hearts and in their minds so whenever they hear this melody, they will remember where they were when they first heard it. They will smile, look towards the one they love and be reminded of all the gorgeous reasons to live.”

Izuku shakily exhaled, feeling like he was in a dream.

“Without further delay,” Souta mused with his charming smile. “Let us get started with the opening number.”

He turned with quiet authority, spine straight as a taut bow. With a measured breath, he lifted his baton. The violinist and violist raised their instruments in tandem.

Then the song began.

The Dance of The Love Birds wove in and out of Izuku’s ears, humming and leaving goosebumps along his skin. The music elegantly flowed, like a gentle river of memory. Without warning, Izuku was suddenly carried through his life by the song.

He saw the beginning, tragic and grey. Sterile halls with no warmth surrounded him as he struggled to survive. It continued like this, fully black and white with no color as the tempo picked up. The viola danced low to the ground while the violin flew above as all of Izuku’s childhood fell before his eyes.

Then—a pop of color.

Blond. Red.

He saw Katsuki, small and scowling. He was standing across the street from him, both of them drawn like moths to the same street violinist’s melody—this melody. It played in the distance of that memory like fate itself humming beneath the snow. Izuku watched as the color bled into the greyscale world. It was slow at first. Then it came crashing in all at once, until Katsuki shone like fire in the night.

The music surged upward with the violin’s rise, light and bright. Izuku saw them again beneath the shattered wings of the stone angel. He saw the two of them dancing in the beams of stained glass that poured through broken cathedral windows.

Then soon the tempo slowed and he was flung forward. He was older now, alone but searching. Grey was all around him again. The little color he did see was only a figment of his imagination. He was wandering through life lined with ghosts, clinging to flickers of red and blond that passed by.

Then the music popped, loudly. The violin and viola joined together in a way that caused Izuku’s memories to flood with hues—it filled with Katsuki.

Katsuki was older now, stubborn and golden. He stepped back into his life like he’d never left. He saw their years together unfold—two people orbiting each other like twin melodies,

always on the verge of melting together. Their bodies moved as one like staves on a page, looping in harmony.

Fighting. Finding. Forgiving.

Then more saturation spilled into his heart as he saw them kiss. He saw them finally collide and suddenly the whole world was painted in large, vivid strokes of chroma that Izuku never thought was possible.

That's when it clicked: all the color in his life was Katsuki.

He turned to the man beside him at that moment.

His husband was in a trance. His hand covered his mouth as he watched the performance on stage with glassy eyes. When a tear fell from Katsuki, Izuku saw it plainly. All the gorgeous reasons to live—not simply survive.

Katsuki had given him purpose to push on—to feel something so utterly soul consuming that he had no choice but to be reminded he was human. He had no choice but to be reminded that he wasn't solely an empty husk.

But rather, he was a person who deserved to experience life so beautiful it would make him cry. It would make him smile. It would make him angry, sad, happy and a mix of all the emotions he was always told to beat down in his body.

Katsuki truly had reminded him to *live*.

Izuku lost himself to the rest of the concert, drowned underneath the sound of the strings.

ᔓᔓᔓ

By the end of the hour concert, Izuku and Katsuki were moved to silence. There were no words that could describe the pure feeling that danced along their skin.

The melodies of the songs they heard, beginning with the one that started it all, made them feel like they were born again. Cleansed in the magic of the music along with everyone else in the audience.

It wasn't until the thunderous applause swelled around them that they were pulled out of their spell. They rose with the rest of the crowd, clapping in unison. Their movements were slow, weighed down by sheer astonishment.

Izuku cried softly, smiling the whole time.

The man who had once been a rambling violinist of their past had fully transformed into a master of emotion. Izuku's chest ached with pride and the bittersweet taste of a long lost childhood pushed to the edge of his tongue.

In the past, he had found the violinist to cross his mind. A lot. The man was the first person Izuku had made contact with on the outside. He showed Izuku that his hands were capable of doing something other than killing when he was eight, and he was the first person besides Katsuki to teach him about the concept of kindness.

So to see him now, fully back on his feet, felt like a long lost wish come true.

Souta smiled wide beneath the lights as roses rained down from the balconies. Izuku wished he'd thought to bring some. In their place, he cheered until his throat hurt and clapped until his palms stung. Together, the violinist, the violist and Souta all bowed. They waved and smiled until the crimson curtains dropped.

When Izuku turned, he found his husband's eyes were rimmed red. A single trail of tears poured freely down his cheek in a delicate, shimmering line. Katsuki let out a shaky laugh as he wiped his tears away with the heel of his hand.

He glanced at Izuku and smiled, full and unguarded.

"That was the best thing I've ever fucking seen," Katsuki said through a cracked voice, half-laughing, half-crying.

Izuku let out a choked laugh of his own. "Yeah," he breathed, wiping at his cheeks uselessly.

Katsuki reached out and brushed the lingering wetness away with a trembling thumb. They stood there for a moment, grinning like fools, bathed in the golden light of the theater.

Then Katsuki's brows pulled together, eyes flicking toward the curtain.

"We have to go find him," he said urgently.

Izuku agreed and they clasped hands.

Quickly, they turned and began to explain everything to the rest of the group. They urged how important it was they found the composer, lightly mentioning how it was related to their year in Tokyo. Aizawa, Miruko and Monoma seemingly agreed.

The five of them quickly walked out into the crowd. Izuku led them along, pushing through the crowd as gently as possible.

When they breached the lobby, the old violinist was easy to spot.

He stood in front of the statue of the golden angel, surrounded by a small group of elderly women. All of them were laughing and fawning over him with bundles of roses as he bashfully swayed on his heels.

Izuku and Katsuki exchanged wide-eyed glances, their grips tightened. They waited, patient and quiet, until the group began to peel away.

Finally, Souta turned to them with the same warm eyes that had followed them all their lives.

“Hello there!” Souta said brightly. “Did you enjoy the show?”

“We did,” Katsuki replied, his voice a little too stiff at first. He nodded, almost conservatively. Very unlike the man he usually was, and so much like the boy he used to be. “We more than enjoyed it, actually.”

“We—” Izuku began, then faltered. He cleared his throat and tried again. “We wanted to ask you something. If that’s alright.”

“Of course,” Souta replied warmly. “Ask me anything.”

They both shifted awkwardly.

Their silence stretched just a little too long, the nerves tripping them up in tandem.

Somewhere behind them, Aizawa let out a barely audible sigh, and Izuku winced inwardly. He hadn’t felt like a kid in a long time. And right now, he felt like they were both those vulnerable, innocent boys that found each other at the edge of the world.

“I’m Katsuki,” his husband said finally, his voice steadier now. “And this is Izuku. We used to hang around you a lot. In San’ya, Tokyo. About eighteen years ago?”

Souta’s smile faltered. His brows drew together slowly. Izuku held his breath as he watched realization unfurl across the man’s face. His eyes darted all over. To their hair, eyes, then finally their intertwined hands.

“We were there,” Katsuki added quietly, “When you first started refining your opening song.”

Souta gasped. His hands lifted instinctively, hovering in the air like they weren’t sure what to do. Then his whole face lit up with wonder—bright and full of memory.

“Oh my goodness,” he whispered. “It’s you! My little ones!”

His eyes danced between them, widening even further. Then he blinked, took in their adult frames, and laughed softly.

“Or—well, not so little anymore. Either of you,” Souta laughed with a delicate grin.

Izuku chuckled through the knot in his throat, even as tears pushed forward in his eyes again.

“This is incredible,” Souta breathed, clasping his hands together. He stepped closer to them and joy, appreciation and admiration all sewed together at once. He opened his arms then, without hesitation, beckoning. “Well? What are you standing there for? Come give me a hug!”

Izuku and Katsuki stepped forward at the same time, unable to stop the wide, tearful smiles on their faces.

Souta pulled them both into his bony arms with surprising strength. Izuku sank into the embrace, arms wrapping tightly around the man who had unknowingly stitched both music

and Katsuki into the seams of his life.

Izuku choked back a happy sob as he held on tighter.

Souta then pulled back and took a good look at them both. He nodded in approval, grinning with his crooked teeth this time. He was still missing a few, but now they seemed well taken care of.

“I can’t believe this,” he whispered. His eyes dropped to their intertwined hands once more and a proud smile graced his lips. “You’ve been reunited. All my life I thought you two were separated for good after you left. But you’re here. Together!”

Katsuki wiped his tears off his face. He shook his head and dryly laughed, “What are the chances, huh?”

Souta tutted his finger. “There’s no such thing as chances, little one. It’s always fate.”

Fate.

Izuku frailly smiled at that.

“I’m so happy to see you’re doing well,” Izuku said softly, stepping back as their embrace loosened. “I thought about you a lot, after everything. I was worried something bad happened to you.”

Souta’s face warmed with affection. “I was able to get my life together again because of you both,” he said. “When you stopped coming around, it was hard. I didn’t realize how much I relied on the two of you. Your presence, your ears, and your belief in me was like medicine. You two helped me process the grief of my wife’s passing.” He exhaled shakily. “You were the best audience I have ever—no. You are the best audience I will ever have.”

He looked at Izuku then. A deeply grateful expression shined through his brown eyes.

“And that money you gave me?” He said. “I used it to get a tiny hotel to live in, something stable. That gave me time to breathe, and get on my feet again.”

“I’m glad it helped,” Izuku said gracefully.

“There aren’t enough ‘thank yous’ in the world for it,” Souta replied, shaking his head. “I decided then to get myself cleaned up. I wanted to try my hardest to play my music for a crowd again since the song was now perfect. I also secretly hoped if I played my song, you two would be reunited by it again one day. Exactly like you were the first time.”

“You were right,” Katsuki chuckled. “We were, in a roundabout way.”

Izuku smiled. “Adding in the viola was a perfect touch. I always assumed that song was a solo.”

Souta’s eyes twinkled with playfulness. “It was always a duet,” he said, winking between them. “It was never meant to be played alone.”

Izuku and Katsuki exchanged smiles.

“Enough about me!” Souta sparked with life. He clapped his hands together and tugged them to his chest. “Tell me, how have the two of you been?”

Katsuki shrugged. “We’ve—We’ve been great.”

“Yeah,” Izuku agreed. He laughed, because clearly that was not the truth with their situation. But right here and now, in the moment, they were.

Souta beamed. He turned eagerly to Katsuki, eyes gleaming. “Please tell me you grew up to be a composer!” he exclaimed. “Your ear for harmony and timing—it’s like listening to a clockmaker fine-tuning the gears of a symphony. I couldn’t have pulled off that piece without you.”

Then he turned to Izuku, warmth deepening in his voice. “And you! I’ve never seen anyone take to the violin the way you did that year. You played like someone who’d stumbled upon a buried part of his soul and was aching to let it sing! Surely, you both stayed in music?”

Izuku grew sad for a second.

But then Katsuki wrapped an arm around him and lovingly squeezed his shoulder.

“We’re working on it,” Katsuki replied. “We’re actually leaving Japan soon for a, uh, fresh start. You could say. But we’re both really damn happy we got the chance to see you again before we headed out.”

Souta perked up. “You’re leaving together?” He glanced between them. “Like you meant to before?”

“Yeah,” Katsuki replied. He looked at Izuku like he was the answer to all his worries. “We are.”

Katsuki’s smile then faded. It bled into that soft apprehension Izuku had been noticing all week. The longer his husband’s eyes stayed fixed on him, the more the nervous bundles inside of him grew.

“Actually,” Katsuki said softly. He shifted his stance, squaring his body towards Izuku fully, like he was bracing for impact. “There was something I wanted to do tonight. I was going to wait until later but—I can’t think of a better time than to do it now.”

His arm slowly slipped from Izuku, breaking their hold with deliberate care. He cleared his throat.

Izuku’s brow pinched, unease churned in his stomach. “Kacchan?”

Katsuki took a step back. His movements were taut with purpose and his jaw was clenched. There was a look in his eyes that Izuku identified as Katsuki’s bullish resolve. Then, Katsuki’s hand went to his coat pocket. The crowd behind them blurred into silence, their motion slowing like a dream as Katsuki willfully dropped to one knee.

Izuku froze. His lungs locked.

The moment unfolded in total clarity. The soft scuff of Katsuki's knee meeting the marble tile. The flick of the velvet box opening in his hand. The warm glow of the chandelier catching on the eternity wedding band that was studded with rubies all the way around.

"Bakugou Izuku," Katsuki said, his voice cracked around the edges but was steady at its core. He pushed the ring up and fastened Izuku's gaze. "Will you marry me?"

For a moment, Izuku could only blink. His mouth parted in disbelief. His vision swam, and his heart swelled with a chaotic rush of affection, terror, joy, and surprise.

"Wh-What—" Izuku stammered, heart careening wildly in his chest. "We're already married —"

"—Marry me again," Katsuki insisted. His grip on the ring box tightened, his voice went hoarse. "*Sober* this time."

His eyes were intense, set on getting an answer. They were burning bright with that unique, Katsuki intensity. And behind all that fire, there was an ache. It was a gash on Katsuki's heart, laid bare and wide open for everyone around them to see. Ruthless, guarded Katsuki had torn himself open just to make space for this moment.

Izuku's chest broke wide.

He sank to his knees without realizing it, overcome by a force too large to be described with words. A sob caught in his throat as he nodded with frantic urgency.

"Yes," he choked out. "Yes, of course, I'll marry you again."

Izuku couldn't stop laughing through his tears. Katsuki joined him, both grinning like damned, lovesick fools. Katsuki took Izuku's hand. He carefully removed the rusted, fake ring and tucked it away in Izuku's pocket.

Then, with teeth bared in triumph and love, he slipped on the new wedding band.

It fit perfectly.

Suddenly, applause erupted around them, breaking the bubble they were in. The blurry background came back into focus and Izuku frantically looked up to see Miruko whistling and clapping like a madwoman, Aizawa was folding his arms with a satisfied nod, and Monoma rolled his eyes but was smiling despite himself.

Other guests joined in, voices lifting like the rise of a tide. Everyone's cheers echoed through the small lobby.

Souta was now also in tears, clapping his frail hands. He grinned with all his crooked teeth, laughing exactly the way he used to.

"My little ones," Souta whispered. "My fated little ones."

Then Souta bent down for the violin case that was at his feet. He opened the case with a swift click, and reached for his brand new, bright white violin. He elegantly held it up, poised and ready with the bow.

The three of them all exchanged looks, and Izuku truly felt like he was in a fairytale at that moment.

“Let me offer you a dance,” Souta volunteered. “To celebrate your real marriage.”

Without a word, he began to play. It was their song again, The Dance of The Love Birds, spinning around with the magic Souta used to play eighteen years ago.

Katsuki pulled Izuku gently to his feet.

Izuku followed, dazed, and they moved together. Laughter spilled into the air as they bumped together awkwardly at first. Then slowly, like always, they found their rhythm. Their push and pull. Their chase and follow. They stepped and twirled.

They swayed as the song wrapped around them with gentle nostalgia this time, binding them together under the golden angel. They held eye contact the whole time, the world allowing them to spin.

And when the music ended, the applause quieted into a hush of soft murmur of stifled sniffles and congratulatory whistles. Izuku gazed at his husband, and for once, the stars felt aligned in all the right places.

Katsuki pulled him in for a fierce embrace.

Izuku buried his face against Katsuki’s shoulder and held on with every ounce of strength he had. His chest trembled with the weight of love too big to speak aloud.

His husband’s breath tickled his ear.

“Sorry for the ambush,” he said. “I wanted it to be a surprise. Y’know, romantic and all.”

Izuku smiled against Katsuki’s beating heart. “It was. Well done.”

ᔓᔓᔓ

When they arrived back at the cabin, Izuku was greeted with a surprise ‘Engagement’ party. Turns out, all the sneaking around and secrecy was all done to keep Katsuki’s efforts hidden.

Confetti rained down from a crude paper banner that read “*Engaygement*!” in bold, hand drawn rainbow bubble letters. Shinsou stood just behind the couch, holding the end of a party popper, stoic but clearly present. Denki was waving a self-made pride flag and jumping in place like a kid on a sugar high. All while Sero was already pouring champagne into mismatched glasses from the kitchen island.

Izuku couldn't stop himself from grinning from ear to ear. Everyone in the cabin gave them a pat on the shoulder and some embraced Izuku for a hug. Shinsou kept his distance but still offered a half hearted smile when he saw how happy the two of them were.

Awaiting them in the party was a secondary velvet box. Izuku opened it and inside was a matching eternity wedding band—full of emeralds.

Katsuki humbly pulled off his old, fake ring and held up his left hand.

"Well," he said with a smirk. "What are you waiting for, darling?"

Izuku grinned and slid the ring onto his husband's finger. His heart skipped a beat as their matching bands glimmered together underneath the cozy light of the cabin.

Miruko then cleared her voice and tapped a fork against her glass of champagne.

"A toast!" Miruko yelled. "To Katsuki and his *darling*," she teased. Everyone grinned, amused and both Izuku and Katsuki blushed deep red. "But more importantly, to their future new life!"

Everyone gathered around the kitchen table and raised their glasses. Each one of them caught gazes, warm and content.

"To round two, but make it consensual!" Monoma added, smug and loud.

"To love!" Denki said with a mock-sappy expression.

"To a real ring," Sero deadpanned, earning a laugh from the group.

Izuku raised his glass, hand trembling slightly, and grinned so wide it made his cheeks ache.

"To all of you. I don't…I don't have any words," Izuku whispered. His throat tightened again and his heart began beating erratically. "Thank you all. For being so kind. I didn't know it was possible to feel happy like this and I'm just thankful you're all are, er, tolerating me being here and willing to take me on as a client."

The looks from the other agents grew empathetic.

"We're not simply *tolerating* you, Izuku," Aizawa retorted. He patted his shoulder and Izuku felt tears of warmth well up in his eyes again for the hundredth time today. "We're happy you're here. And we're happy we can do something to help you and this hot-head get a second shot."

Everyone hummed in agreement and Shinsou even seemed to sway.

"C'mon!" Denki laughed cheerily. "Let's get this party started. I want this to be a night none of us will forget! That way when you guys go off grid, you'll miss us."

Denki pouted playfully and Katsuki scoffed, but smiled regardless.

The night continued on with a kind of joy Izuku had never known. It was a deep, rich elation that soaked through to the bone. It was the kind of bliss that made him feel almost winded, like laughter had replaced his need for oxygen.

Every time he thought the celebration might slow, someone would shout out a new toast, or a new song would blast from the old radio, or another bottle of champagne would snap open with a triumphant pop.

Izuku laughed so hard his ribs started to ache.

His face flushed candy pink from the drinks. He tried to decline a couple, but Monoma handed them to him with no room for argument. Sero, Denki, and Miruko began dancing. The trio shouted and hugged Izuku too tightly. Izuku nearly squealed when one particular hug from Miruko lifted him clean off the ground.

Then half way through, Aizawa brought out a cake. It was a simple, vanilla flavor with pink frosting. The only decoration on the top were two poorly drawn rings in gold.

Half way through the night, Katsuki went and grabbed the disposable camera they had picked up on their road trip.

“Take a picture of us,” he asked Sero with his face flushed from alcohol. “Don’t make it look bad either!”

Sero laughed and captured a couple photos the best he could.

In each photo, Katsuki and Izuku were tightly hugging each other. They proudly held up their new, matching wedding bands. There was soft laughter in the background when Katsuki grinned and swayed. The shimmering look of bliss on his face was so strong that it made everyone in the room emotional.

Through his drunken haze, Izuku could have sworn he saw Aizawa quickly wipe a tear away from his eye.

When they finished taking pictures, Katsuki turned to him with half lidded eyes.

“You’re all mine now, darling,” his husband said with a lopsided grin.

Izuku giggled back. “I’m going to do my best to make you happy, Kacchan.”

“You already do.”

They smiled and rested their foreheads together.

Denki and Sero clapped then forced them to toast again to their sweet moment.

Eventually, Izuku was beginning to sweat through his sweater. But truthfully, he didn’t care. The air was thick with the smell of cake, pine logs, and the scent of whatever body spray Denki had practically bathed in. Someone had opened the balcony doors at one point to let in the cold air, and it barely made a dent in the growing heat.

The warmth in the room wasn't strictly from the fireplace though. It came from the small group of people packed inside. It was the collection of friendship and found family. Everyone was celebrating the bonds built over late nights, bruised knuckles, and silent trust that ran far deeper than words.

At some point in the night, Sero challenged Monoma to a drinking contest and lost—then challenged him again out of pride and lost again.

Everyone was howling with laughter as Shinsou rolled his eyes and refilled their glasses anyway. Denki tried to freestyle rap to a slow piano ballad and got booed good-naturedly by everyone except Sero, who beatboxed with a wine bottle against his leg in undying support.

Shinsou refused to participate in any dancing until Miruko yanked him into a group number with the rest of them. And even then, his grumpy two-step was enough to get a full standing ovation.

Izuku found himself spun around the rug in dizzying circles when Sero grabbed his hand and dragged him into the middle of the room. They moved like idiots to a cheesy pop remix Aizawa had thrown on. He tried to keep up, but was too fast and off-beat. The both of them tripped over their own feet, but really none of it mattered.

Izuku's chest ached from smiling.

His breath came out in gasps between bouts of laughter.

Katsuki joined in only once, grumbling that he hated dancing in front of people—which Izuku called out as a flat out lie. He grabbed his husband's wrist and yanked him towards the bustling living room. They stomped together through the mess of it until they were both breathless. Katsuki's hands found a home on his waist to steady them as they laughed like kids, drunk on the sheer ridiculousness of their love.

After several more hours of drinks, board games that Katsuki dominated for some reason, and blissful company, the party began to ebb. The energy mellowed out and people began settling into the couches, chairs, and even the floor. In everyone's hands were plates of cake or half-filled drinks. The music softened into background melodies.

Izuku found himself curled beside Katsuki on one of the large couches.

His husband's hand was idly tracing the bones of his knuckles. Every now and then he'd glance down at their new rings and grin hazily.

"I like these much better," Katsuki said with a slight slur.

"Me too," Izuku chuckled back. "How did you get them so fast? It hasn't even been a week since you asked."

"I badgered Aizawa," Katsuki admitted. "He told me there was a jeweler down in town that could push out a quick, custom order. After that, I wire transferred him the cash safely from one of my offshore accounts."

“I’ll have to thank him later.” Izuku’s cheeks were hurting from smiling. “He saved us from having to scrub green off our skin every night.”

Katsuki laughed and leaned his head back. He closed his eyes, and began to softly listen to the calm sound of the comforting silence around them.

Izuku took a look around. It was surreal, how everything felt both loud and peaceful.

The others still chatted around them, voices rising and falling. Sero was snoring somewhere on the carpet with his arm thrown over Denki’s stomach. Miruko had her feet propped on the coffee table, poking Shinsou in the ribs every time he looked like he might fall asleep sitting up. Monoma had kicked off his shoes and was reading the back of a champagne bottle aloud like it was Shakespeare.

Izuku leaned his head on Katsuki’s shoulder and let out a long, slow breath.

“Your friends are so nice,” he murmured. “I don’t want this to end.”

“It doesn’t have to,” Katsuki replied. “We can invite these idiots to our wedding once we get settled in. The second we’re in the clear we’re going to have a nice, quiet ceremony exactly like you wanted.” He paused then scoffed with a smirk. “Well. Maybe, not so damn quiet with this lot. But it’s hard to get rid of migraines. They’ll be around.”

Izuku shut his eyes and nodded, swallowing past the lump in his throat.

It was here he realized this party wasn’t only about them or the proposal.

This was a send off, in the best of ways.

He looked around the room once more, eyes misting as he soaked in the sleepy mess of his new acquaintances.

Aizawa was beginning to pour out half drank glasses and rinse some of the dishes off. Their gazes met for a moment and he nodded with a gentle smile at Izuku. Izuku smiled back, and he leaned in further to his husband. He decided he really liked this group. This loud, ridiculous, painfully loyal crowd who had all somehow conspired with Katsuki to make this night unforgettable.

Izuku took another look at his new wedding band.

When he held it up, his breath caught somewhere between his lungs and his throat. It was like his body couldn’t quite keep up with the awe sprouting inside him. He turned his hand slightly, watching how the light caught the rubies.

He couldn’t believe it—yet there it was. For the first time, it all actually felt real.

A life with Katsuki, *his Kacchan*, was no longer a fleeting dream he clung to in the quiet hours.

All his life, a future with Katsuki had felt like smoke, impossible to grasp. A fleeting concept that he had indulged in every stage in his wretched life—but it was never real.

As children, playing husbands in that crumbling church, it was only pretend. When they dreamed of running away, the promise slipped by. Even in the years Katsuki served as a bodyguard in the periphery of his chaos—the crush Izuku nursed was a private indulgence, never something he believed he could have.

Then in Okinawa, their fake marriage was just that: a performance. No matter how desperately he wished otherwise. And later, in Biei, their time together felt like a honeymoon carved from stolen time.

But now—there were these rings.

They were undeniable proof that he and Katsuki were real. As real as the sun and moon, forever drawn into each other's orbit.

After all the years of almosts and not-quites, their happy ending had finally arrived.

Izuku's faith in fate returned a bit that night.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Fourth Week in Winter Paradise

The next week passed with a new form of kinship in the cabin.

Conversations came easier. Laughter lingered longer. Even Shinsou, who had clung to his wariness like armor, seemed to soften around the edges. There was no dramatic shift to it. No vocal change of heart but the tension in his shoulders eased up. His replies grew less sharp and he no longer looked at Izuku like an active threat.

They crossed paths alone one morning, right outside the kitchen.

Miruko had finished making a fresh pot of coffee and the smell clung to the air. Izuku had been on his way to the reading room, where Katsuki was, with his hands wrapped around a warm mug for his husband.

Then when he turned the corner, he nearly collided with Shinsou. They both cursed in the narrow hallway when Izuku almost poured the hot liquid over both of them.

They made eye contact, and for a moment, neither of them moved.

Shinsou's face flickered with trepidation. But this time, it didn't reach his eyes all the way. Stopping it from taking root was a kinder emotion. It filled his deep, violet gaze. He regarded Izuku like he was an entirely different person. One that he had spent days watching, listening, and trying to understand.

“You really care a lot about him,” Shinsou said. His eyes surveyed Izuku carefully. “Don’t you?”

Izuku’s fingers tightened around the mug. He nodded slowly, eyes dropping to the floor as if the admission might make the hallway shrink.

“I always have,” he replied in a disarming whisper. “And I always will.”

Shinsou didn’t say anything back right away. For a moment, there was only the creak of the wood beneath their feet.

Then, without a word, he stepped forward to walk past him. At first Izuku thought he was going to shoulder-check him. But instead, when Shinsou grew close he hesitantly reached out and grabbed Izuku’s shoulder—gently. His fingers dug slightly into the fabric of his sweater, with a tenderness that translated how much new trust Izuku had nurtured.

“Good,” Shinsou sighed. “I thought that idiot might die alone.”

He then disappeared around the corner elsewhere in the cabin.

Izuku stood there for a moment, stunned. The mug in his hands trembled a bit with him.

But he smiled.

ᔓᔓᔓ

The night before their fifth week in the cabin, Izuku was daring to imagine their escape with Nana.

They were so close to her now. He could practically taste the freedom on the back of his tongue.

It was officially less than a few days away.

Earlier, Aizawa mentioned that within the next couple of days they were going to begin their migration down south.

With the help of his private boat, their road to the other end of the country was going to be smooth sailing. Aizawa had plans to smuggle them through the docks at night in Okinawa. It was sleuth enough that Izuku knew they could easily slip past Yakuza traps.

According to the older agent, it would take about three days to get to Okinawa by boat. So in short, it would be like enjoying a nice, weekend cruise with everyone. Which meant, in two days, they were going to begin the end of their journey.

Izuku fell asleep that night dreaming of it.

His mind was a blurry haze as he drifted into sleep. He fell into his mind gently, picturing him and Katsuki on a boat. The smell of sea salt tickled at his nose, and the winter breeze

brushed across his cheek. He could feel the air progressively get warmer as they moved south.

The dream sequence made him feel like he was floating. Then suddenly, in a strange mirage, a small flower popped up in the middle of the boat.

It was a white thorn apple, perfectly waiting for him.

Izuku curiously examined it, recognizing the flower as poisonous.

He walked towards it, and with every step he took the floorboards of the boat transformed into dirt.

The ground beneath his feet was no longer the boat, but rather it was his old courtyard. His old backyard all the way back in Tokyo boxed him in and made him freeze up. Izuku glanced up and saw the cluster of skyscrapers he grew up in.

They leaned over, eerily watching his every move. All around him was the tall, thick barbed wire fence that was tasked with keeping them trapped.

Izuku's heart raced as he looked around.

Many of his siblings were playing across the field. They were fighting, chasing each other with loud laughter and giggles ringing through the air.

Sen and Himiko darted past him, rough housing in pure bliss. He turned his head as they disappeared into the darkness together. Jin came next, gracefully sparring with Hiryu as Aoyama and Ibara played chess off to the side.

An ominous chill raked across his skin. His throat bobbed, feeling like it was caught on a hook.

Izuku turned his eyes back to the flower in front of him. It was peeking from the ground, an anomaly.

Izuku reached down to grab it—and was forcefully stopped by a large hand clasping around his wrist.

He jerked his head to see Tomura. His brother's waxen face was chilling and his eyes were pools of nothing staring back at him.

Suddenly, the snakes tattooed on his neck and arms moved like they were alive.

The vipers, once inked in obsidian spirals across his pale throat and collarbones, began to pulse. Their scales caught the low light like wet stone. Their forked tongues flickered, tasting the air.

One by one they peeled from Tomura skin with obscene slowness, like wet bandages coming off a corpse, and they dropped to the ground with soft, sickening thuds before slithering forward with awful purpose.

Izuku screamed, but no sound came out. The vipers climbed up his legs, wrapped around his torso, and coiled around his arms. He tried to shake them off but there were too many. They wove around him, hissing and barring their fangs until they wrapped around his neck.

They encased him whole until he was covered entirely in horned vipers.



Izuku gasped awake in a cold sweat.

His heart pounded like it was trying to punch through his ribs. His eyes darted around and he felt out the bed to make sure it was real. He glanced to his side and saw Katsuki sleeping peacefully. His husband was out cold, arm tucked around him.

Relief settled in Izuku's chest as he breathed out.

He shook his head, trying to get the awful imagery out his mind.

He didn't get nightmares frequently, but he was surprised that such a pleasant dream transformed into something so ugly. He grabbed his head when he felt down right woozy from the whiplash of the two sequences.

He inhaled to calm himself. However, his head swam like the room tilted.

Izuku paused. He frowned.

He shook his head again and there was a rock of nausea to his gut that he didn't have an explanation for. He sat up further, confused when his drowsiness wasn't dissipating like it should have. Then when he sat up all the way, a faint scent wafted past Izuku's nose.

He froze.

Terror shot straight down his spine. He recognized that smell.

It was noxious gas.

His instincts kicked in like a switchblade snapping open. He clamped a hand over his nose and mouth, spun toward Katsuki, and shook him violently by the shoulder.

"*Kacchan*!" Izuku harshly whispered. "Kacchan, you need to wake up!"

When Katsuki heard the urgency in his voice, his eyes shot open. He sat up straight, and immediately swayed like he was sea sick. Katsuki coughed violently as he covered his nose with his arm and he quickly jumped to his feet.

They looked at each other, and dread calcified in their cores.

Izuku's heart began to race and he glanced towards the door. There, he saw the thick cloud of gas creep from the crack. It slowly rolled in like the grim reaper, taking its time to drag across the floor.

Within the next split second, the door to their bedroom slammed open. Both Izuku and Katsuki jerked back, getting ready to strike—but it was Aizawa, covering his mouth with a rag.

He stood in the doorway, hair damp with sweat, eyes red-rimmed and wild.

“Below ground,” he hissed. “*Now*.”

Behind him, the hallway was chaos. Denki was hunched over, coughing. Sero looked like he was going to vomit. Monoma had his shirt over his nose, eyes darting back and forth. Shinsou’s hand was clenched around a long blade. Miruko was trying not to inhale as she loaded her gun with a dead-silent click.

Aizawa ran forward. He kicked aside the rug in their room, gripped the hidden handle in the floor, and heaved.

The air was turning thick. Izuku could feel it in his throat, clinging to his lungs. The smell had teeth now—and it was coming for their throats.

“Everyone get in,” Aizawa ordered once he had the hatch open.

Then that’s when they heard the shrill sound of glass breaking from upstairs.

Miruko cursed under her breath and slammed the bedroom door shut. She locked it, bolted it. But it wouldn’t hold for long.

One by one, they dropped through the hatch.

Izuku was the first to go, pulling Katsuki after him. They climbed down the concrete ladder into the emergency bunker. Aizawa expertly maneuvered the rug back over the top of the hatch. That way when he closed it, it would be hidden once more.

And when the hatch shut above them, and Aizawa locked the final bolt, silence fell like a guillotine.

They gasped in the clean air, greedy and loud. Sero dropped to his knees, coughing uncontrollably. Denki was shaking, his fingers twitching like he couldn’t stop them. Monoma wiped his eyes furiously, blinking through the blur. Shinsou groaned, trying to spit out the taste of the poison that accumulated on his tongue

Izuku clutched Katsuki’s hand in a white-knuckled grip as they both hacked uncontrollably.

Right as Denki was about to say something, Aizawa slapped a hand over his mouth and put his finger up in a ‘quiet’ motion.

They all listened intensely.

The sound of more glass breaking was followed by footsteps. Multiple people flooded into the cabin up above them and they could hear them spread out corner to corner. The movements of the people were organized. Tactical in a way that Izuku knew. His stomach

knotted when he heard countless footsteps get closer. He tried to number them and do the math of how many bodies they needed to cut through.

Ten. Twenty. Forty. Sixty.

He lost count as the sound of the people above them became close to a stampede.

Aizawa removed his hand from Denki's mouth and motioned to all of them.

"Everyone needs to make a run for the boats at the base of the mountain," Aizawa whispered low and serious. "There's no point in trying to go toe to toe, there's too many. If you get separated, rendezvous in Nemuro. Now, everyone—go. Put your gear on and grab what you can as quietly and quickly as possible."

They all began to scatter.

As the sound of more people flooded into the cabin, everyone suited up hastily. They had stored extra clothes and bags down in the bunker, in case they needed an emergency exit. Izuku grabbed the backpack pre-packed with guns, knives, and his burner phone. He took out his obsidian daggers and hooked them on his person and threw on his winter coat.

When he turned, Katsuki already had his combat boots on. The others dressed in silence, getting their weapons ready. All of their expressions dived into a lethal seriousness from them that Izuku had not yet seen.

They began to hastily make a move towards the emergency exit when the sound of the bedroom door shook the floor above. With a loud creak and a bang, the heavy object slammed to the floor. In came dozens of people, boots scattering. The footsteps were endless.

But among them, Izuku distinctly recognized one pair.

His blood ran cold.

Tomura's heavy, powerful steps vibrated across the floor.

The drag. The pause. The deliberate thud of heel to wood, like someone who walked not to move, but to announce their presence. Each step didn't just echo. It spread. It crawled down Izuku's spine like rot.

Everyone below the floorboards grew deathly still, afraid of making noise. They eyed the large, metal door to the outside in front of them with bated breaths, weary of getting caught.

Aizawa inched slowly, trying his best to not draw attention.

The people above shuffled loudly, searching every inch of the room. Izuku could hear them go into the bathroom, the closet, he could feel the thud of them turning over the bed.

"We can't find them," a voice of a man said above them. "They must've escaped somehow."

“They couldn’t have gotten too far after we sent that gas bomb down the chimney,” a woman explained.

All the people above them moved about. All but Tomura.

Izuku held his breath when he couldn’t hear his brother shift. He was standing still, cold eyes drinking in every inch of the room no doubt. Everyone tried to get closer to the escape door and beads of sweat began to accumulate on Izuku’s brow.

When they reached the door, Aizawa’s hand clutched the handle tightly, waiting.

Then, Tomura moved. He took a single pace forward and paused.

“The trick is listening closely,” Tomura said, voice smooth and patient.

His feet shifted. He took one, two, three steps and stopped.

“Because if you do,” Tomura drawled. “You can hear the scratching of *vermin* under the floorboards.”

Bullets rained down through the wooden floor.

“Go! *Go*!” Aizawa shouted loudly when the hatch began to be forcefully blown off.

He ripped open the steel metal door and its loud screech cut through all of their ears.

“Surround the parameter!” Izuku heard one of Tomura’s men scream from above. “Don’t let them escape!”

They all poured out the door. They were shot into a narrow, thin passageway that forced them all into a single file line. The cold cut into them as they all worked fast with Aizawa leading the way.

Izuku’s heart was hammering in his ears as they twisted and weaved through the maze in the mountain. The sound of footsteps from the cabin oscillated in and out above them as they ran as fast as they could.

When they breached the exit, they were spit out right on the edge of a cliff. The drop was steep enough to make Denki shriek. They all sharply turned, the snow under their feet crunching with the urgency they kept up.

Aizawa clutched his rifle when the sound of running footsteps from the trail above came into ear shot.

He raised one single arm and formed his hand into a fist.

Immediately all members of M-Unit fell into formation. Without warming, Katsuki grabbed Izuku and threw him in the middle. Suddenly everyone squeezed in tightly around him with their guns drawn. Aizawa took the front and never broke his pace.

When they rounded the corner where the paths collided, gunpowder filled the air. Bullets rained down as everyone began to dodge defensively, keeping Izuku and Katsuki protected. Izuku's instincts homed in as he ducked behind a large tree with Katsuki. Several of the others ducked and rolled, opening fire on their opponents.

Everyone kept close. They ducked, rolled, and fired off their bullets towards the men in black. One by one the Yakuza fell, covering the once fresh snow in bright crimson red.

Izuku's eyes were restricted as he landed several kill shots at Yakuza scum who came too close on their right. Katsuki began reloading, defending his blind spot on the left as more Yakuza spilled from the slope above.

"Move down!" Aizawa commanded and everyone fell in line. "Remember, get to the speedboats!"

They began to run rapidly, trying their best to get away while still defending themselves. They bobbed and weaved through the thick forest, using the trees as cover. Izuku's lungs ignited with fire as he ran from cover to cover progressively down the mountain.

Katsuki was right behind him, hot on his heels keeping his gun lifted and firing. His husband killed anyone that came too close.

Then suddenly, a second wave of bodies came.

They spilled down the mountain like ants, coming in nearly every direction from behind them.

Izuku's eyes widened in horror as they became outnumbered with what seemed like a small army.

They all kicked up the pace, running for their lives.

Denki began cursing repeatedly as he picked up his knees. Sero began reloading. Monoma and Shinsou shined, letting their killer instincts sharpen and slice through the open fire. Monoma's sniper eye took down several people in the distance and Shinsou blew the kneecaps off one man who got too close to their group.

Behind them, Aizawa and Miruko lingered.

Their bodies moved with lethal precision as they engaged the oncoming Yakuza forces. They held them off with their combined years of expertise.

Miruko's trigger finger was a blur. Each bullet landed with unnerving precision, shattering bones and sending the enemies sprawling. Heads snapped back. Chests exploded. Knees buckled mid-charge. And when her chamber clicked empty, she didn't flinch.

One man rushed her, screaming, thinking he could close the gap. She welcomed him. With a feral grin, she dropped low, swept his legs out, and vaulted upward to drive her elbow straight into his throat, crushing his windpipe before he even hit the ground.

All while next to her, Aizawa's heavy shotgun cut through several men at a time. His black coat flared as he reloaded the sawed-off shotgun with practiced ease. When he fired, it was brutal like a fist punching through their torsos.

Clusters of men dropped in heaps, their bodies torn open by buckshot. Aizawa didn't watch them fall. He was already pivoting, reloading, ready for the next wave.

But despite their formidable skills, the sheer number of adversaries was progressively becoming overwhelming.

Miruko, bloodied but unbowed, turned to the them, her voice cutting through the chaos.

"Go! We'll hold them back!" Miruko shouted as she ducked behind another tree. She shot from around the trunk. "We need to split up and shake them off!"

Izuku hesitated. A force unlike any other he ever felt during combat sank in. He inexplicably knew Miruko was right, but the urge to stay by her stopped him. Then Aizawa nodded towards him, his eyes meeting Izuku's with a silent command.

Suddenly, a voice rang out from the distance. A Yakuza commander barked the orders, "Focus your efforts towards the two targets!"

Katsuki's hand clasped around his wrist and they sprinted away.

He did his best to not look back. The sound of gunshots and screams filled the air as they retreated down the mountain path. Their breaths fully ragged as they navigated the treacherous terrain.

Down here, the forest grew thicker. They zig zagged between more trees. Behind them, the sounds of battle grew fainter, replaced by the ominous silence of the forest.

Izuku let out a shaky breath as his legs began to burn. He absorbed the pain and funneled it into fuel.

They quickened their pace, adrenaline fueling their flight. As they reached a new clearing, more Yakuza emerged, their weapons raised.

Immediately everyone began to duck behind the trees. Pieces of bark flew into the air as the bullets soared. Izuku shielded his head as he reloaded his gun. His piercing eyes homed in on three bodies and when he raised his pistol—he sank three precise shots in their temples.

They tried to move, but when they did the Yakuza advanced with them.

They tried to cut through, but as more bodies came into the clearing, they were facing difficulties.

Monoma cursed under his breath as he took down two more men.

He ducked behind a tree when a bullet nicked his cheek. He reloaded hastily. Then, he looked at his comrades. Denki and Sero met his eyes, and so did Shinsou.

A serious firmness settled at the bottom of his Monoma's eyes.

Shinsou nodded once before sprinting towards Izuku and Katsuki. He covered himself as best as he could. He hid behind a tree that was next to Izuku and Katsuki.

"We need to section off," Shinsou harshly yelled to them. "Us three need to go. *Now*."

Izuku's heart sank under the crackling of more gun fire. "But what about them?"

"They're not amateurs," Katsuki hissed, his voice low but confident. His hand clamped around Izuku's wrist again. "They'll hold them off then escape when it's clear."

Quickly, the decision was made for him when Katsuki and Shinsou began running, tugging him along. Izuku ran along with them, using all the spirit he could muster.

This time, Izuku did look back. There he saw the three fighting in a tight formation. Sero, Denki, and Monoma held the opening. They cut down anyone who tried to follow them.

Monoma was all smoke and thunder, his twin pistols spitting out death in rapid bursts, brass shells clinking to the ground as he carved a brutal rhythm through the crowd.

Sero met every oncoming fighter with brutal force, his brass knuckles shattering ribs and elbows, his kicks snapping spines, the sound of bones breaking like drum beats behind them.

And Denki was more lethal with a knife than he let on. He struck like electricity, powerful and fast, sliding through soft flesh with terrifying ease.

Together, they held the mouth of the opening like a dam against a rising flood, refusing to let a single enemy slip past.

The trio disappeared as Izuku skidded down a new hill.

He held his arms out for balance as they rounded, getting closer to their exit.

Shinsou was running ahead of them.

"We're going towards the ski lift!" Shinsou shouted over this shoulder. "At this rate we're not going to make it down by foot. The cable car will get us down quicker!"

Izuku and Katsuki nodded. They sped around a sharp cliff and barreled down with all their might. Cold air filled their lungs like needles, stabbing and jolting them with every hurried step they took. Behind them, Izuku heard the forest scream faintly. Gun fire. Groans. He could only hope it was their side winning out—and not the Yakuza's.

When they came to the second opening, their saving grace was sitting there, rocking in the wind.

And then from the trees, like a nightmare made flesh, a man stepped out. The large man Yakuza leered at them through his one good eye. He was dense with muscle and menace, his breath fogging as he advanced quickly.

Shinsou didn't hesitate. He rounded on his feet with the kind of speed Izuku hadn't seen from him before.

Shinsou struck, fast enough to be invisible until impact. The man staggered, and tried to grab him but Shinsou ducked the first swing. He planted a brutal elbow into the man's ribs, then pivoted and slammed his heel into the side of his knee. Bone cracked. The man howled.

But Shinsou didn't stop—he grabbed him by the collar, twisted, and slammed his skull into the steel girder of the station until the man went slack, leaving a red smear behind. And then there was silence.

They moved again. Faster this time.

Katsuki forcefully pushed Izuku to the front. Before Izuku could think, his husband hoisted him by the waist like deadweight and shoved him frantically into the cable car. The cold metal floor bit through Izuku's pants as he hit it hard, and before he could scramble up—

The sound of ten more footsteps came.

Izuku snapped up right, and from the window of the cable car, he could see more Yakuza. They came from the trees like insects. Some with guns, others with knives, a few with nothing at all.

They attacked Shinsou and Katsuki without any hesitation.

The blur of bodies began to brawl beneath Izuku. Katsuki had already closed the distance to the first, fists landing like gunshots, quick and savage. His entire body twisting with each blow—fully brutal. One man crumpled, but two more took his place. Katsuki lifted his gun and shot two more down.

Shinsou was holding his own, moving like a shadow. Every strike with his long blade was purposeful and every dodge he maneuvered calculated.

Together, Katsuki and Shinsou moved like they'd fought side-by-side their entire lives. Katsuki took high, Shinsou took low, switching seamlessly as they knocked one man back and cut another down.

But they weren't winning—they were surviving.

And then, another wave of attackers came.

Izuku moved to get off the cable car—but the second he emerged, Shinsou whirled his head towards him.

His eyes were wild and his voice boomed, "Stay there!"

Katsuki's eyes met Shinsou's. The space between them charged with an unspoken communication.

And then Shinsou turned, blood on his cheek and fury in his eyes, and shouted, “I’ll see you two at the rendezvous point!”

Before Izuku could process the words, Katsuki leapt for the cable car. Someone tried to grab his leg and Shinsou cut the man’s hand off with a sharp swing of his blade. Blood sprayed across his face as Katsuki hoisted himself up and in the car.

Then Shinsou made a beeline for the control panel at the base of the steel column. A blade slashed across his arm, but he didn’t flinch. Another attacker lunged, but Shinsou ducked, rolled, and came up swinging—his fist colliding with the attacker’s temple so hard that blood sprayed.

He reached the switch.

He punched it to full speed.

The cable car jolted.

It surged forward with a loud whir. Izuku jerked with the force and so did Katsuki. They both grabbed on to each other for balance as the car rocketed away from the station. Cold air hit Izuku like a slap. His heart leapt into his throat as the station shrank behind him.

He watched as Shinsou twisted another man’s arm until the joint gave with a wet pop. He pivoted, using the man’s limp body as a shield against the next attacker’s machete, then slammed his boot into the attacker’s sternum so hard the man flew backwards, landing in a heap on the snow-covered rocks.

The bodies blurred together, shrinking and shrinking, until the figures fighting were shadows.

Izuku’s hands trembled against the steel bars of the cable car. His throat ached from the scream he didn’t release. The car descended, propelling them down the mountain on that groaning wire, until the entire world below was obscured by fog and distance.

“They’ll be okay,” Katsuki said, voice taut. He spit out a glob of blood and wiped his mouth. “Don’t worry. We’ve been in tighter situations as a unit before.”

Izuku wearily looked at his husband, unsure. None of these people had ever faced Tomura.

Right as he was about to reply, the cable shrieked above them. Both of their heads whipped up at the sound of the high-pitched metal-on-metal wail of something snapping.

The line snagged—*violently*.

The car lurched forward with such velocity that Izuku’s skull slammed into the window behind him. A loud cry tore from his throat, and before Katsuki could even curse, the second snag came—louder and sharper.

The line gave.

And then, the world fell.

The entire car sheared free from the cable like a bullet from a chamber, gravity taking hold in one clean, merciless movement. The mountain opened its jaws as the cart tumbled into its throat with no warning.

His stomach dropped first. Sickness rocked all the way up his core as they lifted off the seats. Izuku barely had time to grab hold of Katsuki. His arms hooked around his husband's torso and his face buried in his shoulder.

Then, the impact came.

Katsuki wrapped his arms around Izuku's head, taking the brunt of the next blow with his back, teeth gritted so tight it sounded like they cracked. They were slammed down into the metal floor mercilessly.

Glass exploded off the windows outward like a shrapnel storm. Jagged fragments sliced through the air as the car bounced, skidded, twisted, slammed.

They were a hunk of metal ricocheting down the slope, pinwheeling end over end, every impact punching the breath from their lungs and every jolt a new source of pain. The wind was a scream in their ears.

Metal crumpled. Bones slammed into steel. The ceiling buckled. The floor split. Snow rushed in through the broken windows like smoke.

Suddenly, they collided with something hard, and large.

The force that the cart was stopped with rocked stomach acid into Izuku's mouth.

The cart groaned, lifting to tip over then paused. It fell backwards, and hit the ground with a loud, hard final thud.

Neither of them moved.

A silence so vast and absolute followed that for a moment, Izuku thought he had gone deaf. Then he heard the distant hiss of snow melting against hot metal. Pain bloomed in full color now. His ribs ached. Glass was lodged deep in his thigh. Blood trickled hot down his legs, soaking his pants.

Katsuki moved first.

He hissed in enormous pain as he tried to peel himself upright. Blood dripped from a gash under his eye. He nursed his temple and tried to stop the world from spinning.

Izuku did the same. Broken glass fragments cut into his gloves as he tried to find leverage to pull himself up. Katsuki shoved a jagged sheet of metal out of the way that had fallen from the ceiling. He staggered upright with a groan that sounded less like a man in pain and more like an animal trying to rise from a trap.

He stood to his full height, and tried to find an exit.

Izuku looked around and found total wreckage. If the cable car had been a piece of paper, it was now crumbled. The once smooth metal was bent and torn in several places. The windows were entirely gone, and in their place were sharp left over shards of glass like teeth.

Katsuki yelled out a loud grunt as he pushed against the jammed door on the side. His neck flexed with effort as he gave a full strength haul. The door shrieked and surrendered to Katsuki, popping open and falling to the ground.

Izuku coughed, once, then again. A wet rattle tossed around his chest. He felt something warm come up with it, tasting like blood. He tried to speak for help, but Katsuki was already reaching down and pulling him out from the twisted ruin.

“C’mon,” Katsuki rasped. He hastily bent down and gathered Izuku in his arms. He cradled him fiercely and exited the cable car. “We have to keep moving.”

Katsuki hastily began to run. Izuku hissed when his leg throbbed, glass shards jolting around, deep in his muscles.

“I got you,” Katsuki said shakily as he picked up his pace. “I got you, don’t worry, darling.”

His voice cracked on the last word.

Izuku breathed out, wrapping his arms around Katsuki’s neck. He tried to catch his breath as they kept going. He looked around and found they were at the base of the mountain, completely out of reach of the chaos.

He could hear no more gunshots. No groans or cries. He could barely hear anything besides the frantic panting of Katsuki running as fast as he could.

Izuku wearily looked up to the peak as his heart clutched for the others.

He could only hope they made it out safe.

ɯɯɯ

Katsuki ran the whole way to the coast line with no breaks.

Trees blurred in their periphery. The ugly slush of snow beneath Katsuki’s feet and his rugged panting were the only sounds in the dead of the night. Izuku was sure his husband’s lungs were on fire as they barreled straight into the darkness with no hesitation.

Along the way, Izuku had dug the glass out of his legs. The gashes were deep but he knew he could push past it.

They turned a corner, and in view came one of the marked docks. The boat was there, still hidden under a heavy tarp flapping in the ocean wind. They both looked around, heeding caution and found nothing.

“Do you think the others made it?” Izuku asked, worried.

“They’ll be fine,” Katsuki said, voice firm despite the strain in his breathing. “We’ve done this before. Whenever there’s too many people to take out, everyone is really good at getting to safety. We’ll see them soon, don’t worry.”

They walked out to the dock and with delicate care, Katsuki put Izuku down on his feet again. Izuku flexed out his thighs, working his adrenaline to push down the pain that was shooting up in his legs. He stretched out his limbs and nodded to Katsuki that he was good to go.

Katsuki then yanked the tarp away with one whip motion and the canvas went flying into the wind. Beneath it was a small, motorized white and blue skiff. It was very bare bones but functional.

“C’mon, darling,” Katsuki urged.

Izuku nodded and hastily allowed himself to be led into the boat. Katsuki’s hands helped steady him as he got into the swaying boat. Izuku held out his hands for his husband and Katsuki grasped them tightly as he began to get inside.

Then suddenly, as Katsuki was halfway in, a strange sound cut through the wind.

It was sharp, clean, and almost delicate.

Katsuki choked and stumbled.

Both of their eyes went wide. Like a cruel nightmare they both saw too late, a tiny dart sank its way into the side of Katsuki’s neck.

Izuku scrambled out of the boat when Katsuki staggered backwards.

Quickly, Katsuki ripped the dart free with a snarl of pain, but the paralyzer was already beginning to work its effects. His hands shook with tremors. His body began to lock up and finally, his knees gave out. His eyes rolled into his skull.

“Kacchan!” Izuku screamed.

He shot his arms out and they toppled together with Katsuki’s heavy body dragging them down.

Another dart cut through the dark air. But this time, Izuku was on high alert. He snatched it mid-flight without looking, with his eyes wide and wild. He flung it into the water while cradling Katsuki’s head with one arm. His eyes scanned over the endless trees in front of him for the perpetrator. But found nothing in the deep darkness.

His nostrils flared as he used all his strength to drag Katsuki towards the boat again.

“I got you, Kacchan,” Izuku hissed through a clenched jaw.

The sound came again. Izuku dodged the next dart by a hair. It whistled past his cheek and sank into the side of the boat.

But then another followed. And another.

Izuku deflected both, but a third following too closely slipped past his defense. It buried itself into the base of his neck. Izuku jerked and gritted his teeth. The chemical hit him like a hammer to the skull but he knew he had more time than Katsuki.

His adrenaline pulsed against the push of the sedative.

He began to crawl, dragging Katsuki's sluggish body by the arm toward the boat—inch by miserable inch. His hands were beginning to shake. His balance tilted, leaning like the world shifted ever so slightly. But he kept going. He had to.

"Please," Izuku hissed through gritted teeth to no one. Or, to fate, maybe. "*Please*—"

He made it back to the boat and with a loud groan, lifted Katsuki. He hoisted his husband into their getaway vehicle with all his strength and just when he stepped foot inside, more darts came.

He dodged two, but another, larger one, embedded itself in his leg. He ripped it free, hands trembling. But then another came, biting into his other leg.

Izuku growled low in his throat, ripping the dart out with his bloodied fingers. But another one hit. Then another.

Nausea dragged him down and his vision pulsed.

Izuku began to tremble.

"N-No," he gasped. "No, no—"

The high dose of paralyzer overtook his bloodstream like ice water. His vision tunneled out. A loud, angry defeated cry spilled from his lips. He tried to climb in the boat with Katsuki but his muscles felt like they had been replaced with stone.

His vision blurred.

Then the world stopped.

Izuku fell. His back hit the wooden dock as he collapsed straight down into gravity. He stared wide eyed toward the end of the dock, world spinning in a dizzying circle as he laid completely still against his will.

Something moved at the end of the dock.

A single footstep changed the whole mood.

Dread so visceral crawled up his legs that it felt like his own bones were trying to escape his skin.

The next step came, and Izuku felt fear scream in his skull.

Tomura emerged from the darkness like a phantom, fully sculpted in white.

His coat was the same color as the snow. Knee-length, regal and trimmed in thick white mink fur that shimmered in the ocean wind.

Every inch of him was pristine and polished like a man who truly did sit at the Tokyo Underground Council. White slacks. White gloves. White boots, un-scuffed and heavy against the old wood. He was a true, monochrome devil coming to drag Izuku back to the pits of hell.

The only color on him now was his eyes. Deep, blood red that was so thick Izuku could feel the void consuming Tomura's soul.

His brother's white hair blew softly in the wind and the tattooed vipers on his throat pulsed.

Izuku let out a strangled, involuntary cry. Weak, tiny tremors surged through his hands. He tried to grapple at the wooden dock beneath him. He begged his fingers to move. Just one *inch*. Just enough to drag himself back to Katsuki. Just enough to fight. But his body was locked beneath the weight of terror and toxin.

Tomura approached gradually, savoring each step.

Behind him, a row of Vipers stood tall. He stopped just in front of Izuku and looked down with that cold, clinical detachment that has haunted him since childhood.

"Playtime is over, little brother," is all Izuku heard before darkness consumed him whole.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku came to like a man drowning.

He surged up through the black, lungs heaving against pressure that had no shape. His eyes snapped open and the world tilted violently. The first name that broke through the sludge of his thoughts was Katsuki. Then came the pain. A crackling cough wrecked his chest, and blood coated his tongue with the sharp, metallic sting of iron.

Memory hit him next. It all came in fast, brutal, and incoherent. Gunfire. Snow. The paralyzer bullets soaring through the air. Then nothing.

Izuku groaned as his skull throbbed like it had been cleaved open and stitched back together all wrong. He winced and pressed his lids shut against the spinning.

He tried to catch his breath and get his bearings.

He looked down, vision pulsing in and out of clarity. In the haze, he saw the bindings wrapped around him like a vicious viper. Coarse rope twisted cruelly around his wrists and ankles, strung so tight they chafed his skin raw. Worse, he could feel paralytic humming throughout his muscles and making his limbs heavy like lead.

Quickly, the world sharpened in pieces.

Trees. Stones. Snow. Everything was white and grave level quiet. He frowned when he looked around longer. An eerie familiarity itched at him like a tick sucking blood.

No. This wasn't right. This couldn't be right.

The chill in his gut dropped further when he recognized the grove. Dead Higanbana flowers littered the snow-packed forest floor like red-brown ash. All the trees stood around barren and black against the night sky. Their branches were pointed at him, skeletal and accusing.

Ahead of Izuku lay a familiar slope of graves. They were aligned in neat, long, rows winding across the earth.

He was at the Bakugou Estate in Biei.

More specifically—he was at the family grave site.

Right as his confusion grew, his eyes finally focused in and snagged on what was happening in front of him.

His heart dropped and ice filled his veins.

No.

No. No. No.

Directly across from him, Katsuki knelt in the snow.

He was bound in plastic zip-ties thick enough to cut off his circulation. His head hung low and his jaw was clenched. Rigidness seized his shoulders with either defiance or terror. Or maybe it was both. Three Yakuza men with rifles circled him like vultures. And behind him was a pile of fresh dirt.

A fresh, shallow grave had been dug directly beside the resting place of Bakugou Mitsuki.

And in addition, a new headstone already stood tall. Etched into polished black granite read 'Bakugou Katsuki' in clear, crisp etching.

Izuku called out for Katsuki. But the sound was smothered into a muffled howl into the gag tied around his mouth. He thrashed, frantic and useless. His muscles barely twitched under the drug's chokehold. Panic so urgent surged through him until his vision pulsed white.

Katsuki's head snapped up, and their eyes met. His husband's expression collapsed into horror, but before he could say anything, the shadows moved.

Two massive Yakuza thugs seized Izuku by both arms, jerking him upright to his knees. Their grip was deliberately punishing as they manhandled him. Izuku gasped through his nose, the cloth in his mouth soaked through with saliva tasting like mildew and ash.

“Ah. Finally awake,” Tomura spoke.

His brother strolled into his view languidly. His coat flared with every step, bone-white against the bleak, wintry cemetery.

“I’m only half sorry for the headache you must have,” Tomura said coldly. “We had to hit you with extra dosages for obvious reasons.”

Izuku screamed again, hoarse and guttural.

He tried to plead. He tried to bargain past the cloth, but his brother wasn’t listening. Tomura turned his back on him, making it clear he had no more mercy left to give. He walked straight up to Katsuki and glared down at him like he was dirt beneath his shoe.

Izuku thrashed harder. He tried to say, “Get away from him!”

But the gag swallowed his voice.

“However,” Tomura continued. “I am fully sorry that it took me so long to come collect you. I admittedly have known where you were the last three weeks. But Chisaki had this headstone specially made and it was only delivered today.”

Tomura delicately ran a gloved finger down over the curve of the headstone.

“He has a twisted sense of humor,” Tomura said.

Izuku made an attempt to call out his brother’s name.

“At least now you’ll be next to your dearest mother, Katsuki,” Tomura taunted, with a hint of disgust. “Mother and son. Forever side by side, doomed by the weight of their mistakes.”

“Fuck you,” Katsuki sneered through gritted teeth. “I’m going to kill you with my bare hands after this.”

Their gazes collided. Searing heat met glacial indifference and the silence between them quivered like a taut wire on the brink of snapping.

Tomura’s upper lip curled, and his expression grew icier by the second.

He slowly walked back over to Izuku and crouched down to his level. He hooked his finger under the gag and with a sharp flick of his wrist, he slipped the gag down from Izuku’s mouth. It landed like a sodden rag on his chest.

“Tomura,” Izuku sobbed, fully unraveling. “I’m sorry—” another wrecked sob. “I’m sorry. Don’t hurt him. Please.”

Tomura’s eyes glared down at him unwavering. But Izuku had to try. He had to convince Tomura not to go through with this—so he continued. He groveled until he felt his lips chap under the weight of all his desperation. Katsuki was looking at him in the most heartbreaking way as every new word slipped past his lips.

But no pleas were able to penetrate Tomura's tundra.

"Don't hurt him," Izuku begged. "Tomura, I love him. Please."

Tomura didn't waiver. His eyes narrowed.

"You know he doesn't care about you, Izuku," Tomura berated, low and dispassionate. "Did he tell you about our deal?"

Izuku stilled.

Deal?

The word hung like an executioner's blade mid-fall.

His storm of frenzied thoughts slowed for a brief moment, caught on the word. He furrowed his brow trying to connect it somewhere. But he couldn't. Something was missing. Out of the corner of his eye, he could see Katsuki lock up. Soon, all the color from Katsuki's face drained and a new look of horror was spreading across his features.

Tomura lifted a brow.

"Ah." He patiently clasped his hands. "He didn't tell you."

Izuku's silence deepened. His eyes flitted between his husband and his brother. He steadily grew more and more confused.

Katsuki began shaking his head. It was a subtle, terrified gesture.

"Izuku," Katsuki rasped, voice serrated with panic.

He began to struggle against his zip ties. He tried to lurch forward but one of the men guarding him stepped in. He pointed his rifle directly between Katsuki's eyes as a warning. Katsuki choked back a sob as his scarlet eyes latched on to green.

"Izuku, I swear to god I was going to tell you—"

"—He was going to trade you in," Tomura cut in, his voice a venomous whip. "Hand-deliver you to me like an offering. Just for a shot at his pathetic revenge."

"I changed my mind!" Katsuki screamed the words, fully guttural and with monstrous pain. His expression crumbled down and he turned his furious gaze on to Tomura. "You know I changed my mind the second I realized who the fuck you were!"

Tomura didn't blink. "Still," he said. "The thought alone is proof enough you don't deserve Izuku."

Katsuki thrashed, rabid. Another guard had to restrain him, and Katsuki fought him every step of the way.

“No! No, Izuku, *please*—I had changed my fucking mind!” Katsuki’s voice cracked, splitting right down the dead center. “Izuku, I—”

But the rest didn’t come. It stuck in his throat like a shard of glass. He hesitated, chest rising and falling with heartbreak as tears streaked through the blood and dirt on his face. He was sobbing now, chest wracked, words failing as grief took over.

“I’m so fucking sorry,” Katsuki groveled, and Izuku’s eye’s grew wider. “I—I didn’t know everything back then. I didn’t have the whole picture or know anything. I was so fucking *angry*, Izuku. I was blinded by my rage—”

Tomura rolled his eyes and snapped his fingers. “Gag him.”

One of the guards stepped forward without hesitation and jammed a filthy rag deep into Katsuki’s mouth, cutting him off mid-apology. Katsuki convulsed against his restraints until his skin bled raw. He was still pleading with his life and trying to apologize through his eyes alone.

Izuku stared back, unblinking. His heart began pounding at the highest tempo it had ever reached.

He searched those scarlet eyes—weighing every tremor in Katsuki’s expression for some sign of manipulation. Some sort of twist that he could cling to. But there was none.

Tomura was telling the truth.

“I told you Izuku,” Tomura hissed. “I may be cruel, but I would never lie to you. Unlike me, this mutt jumped at the idea to trade you in to me, all for a shot to kill Chisaki. I told him if he brought me you, he could get his revenge—and he agreed. How else do you think he found you so quickly after the masquerade? *I’m* the one who told him what car you took after noticing which one was missing from the garage.”

Izuku shook his head in disbelief.

He reeled back, terrified and struggling to swallow the truth.

But the pieces fit. They clicked into place into the grand scheme of the puzzle. Now, Izuku felt sick for an entirely different reason. His head swam again and betrayal sank into his gut. It climbed into his throat and cut off the air from his lungs to his head. His world fell off its axis.

Katsuki was drenched in absolute shame. His tears free fell to the ground and he was hunched over trying to translate a thousand sorrys with his eyes.

Then Tomura sighed. He stood up and lightly brushed his white pants.

“We’re done here,” Tomura declared with finality, already turning away. “I’ve wasted enough time with this childish runaround. Bring in the coffin.”

The world stilled.

“Coffin?” Izuku whispered, the sound barely a breath.

He didn’t have time to process the shape of the word before four Vipers entered in formation. The thud of their boots marched in unison like the tolling of a funeral bell. They moved with the kind of brutal efficiency born of repetition. Their faces were hidden behind porcelain masks, not human, not even curious.

Between them they carried a box, long and narrow. It was hewn from coarse, black-stained wood.

The breath that left Izuku’s lungs was sharp, like a wounded animal. Horror detonated behind his eyes. He surged forward without thinking, and a scream shredded itself from the pit of his chest.

“*No*!” he shouted, voice fraying into hysteria. “Stop! Tomura, *please*! Don’t do this!”

Tomura didn’t flinch. He didn’t so much as even turn his head.

“You’re still bleeding through your heart for him?” Tomura asked. He spoke as if he was explaining a tired truth to a child too naive to understand. “Even after what I just told you? You really are foolish, Izuku. But I suppose that’s my fault for sheltering you so much.”

The coffin touched the ground with a heavy, inevitable thud.

“Tomura, please don’t—” Izuku begged. He looked up to Tomura with bleary eyes. “Big Brother, don’t do th-this. I’ll marry Chisaki—I’ll go back with you, I swear. I’ll do whatever you want, just—don’t kill him. Please. *Please*—”

Tomura stayed silent as he walked behind him.

He lifted the cloth to gag Izuku once more. He cinched the rag tight until Izuku’s jaw screamed in pain. Izuku struggled against the men holding him down, but the overwhelming dose of paralyzer in his vein was like heavy metal now. It made its way at home in his limbs as his immune system failed to rebound like it used to.

Katsuki’s chest surged with breath, like a furnace pulling its last draw of air.

Then, the two large Yakuza guards roughly hoisted Katsuki to his feet. He fought them every second in a violent, strong thrash. He kicked, slammed an elbow into someone’s ribs hard enough to crack, bucked and twisted like a beast that refused the slaughterhouse.

At one point, Izuku thought he might escape. Katsuki’s indomitable strength began to burn right through them. But then, the four Vipers cocked their rifles. Cold steel was pointed directly at Katsuki in all directions.

Katsuki froze.

With clenched teeth, Katsuki was roughly positioned in front of his coffin. He stood there on his feet like a man on death row with red rimmed eyes.

Tomura approached Katsuki. Their gazes clashed and the eerie silence broke through the air.

Tomura gestured for one of the Yakuza men to de-gag Katsuki. When the cloth fell, Tomura stared expectantly at him.

“Any more lies you want to confess?” Tomura mocked.

Katsuki snarled and spat directly in his face.

The spit hit like a slap. Tomura closed his eyes on reflex, but remained chillingly composed. He lifted his hand slowly, and wiped the disrespect off his face. His nostrils flared with sheer, controlled rage. When he opened his eyes again, his gaze was pure hatred, right down to the marrow.

He stepped back, glare sinking into Katsuki like one of his machetes.

“Actually,” Tomura muttered, as if suddenly remembering a misplaced trinket. He extended his hand with the same cold indifference one might offer to collect a knife. “I almost forgot __”

One of the Vipers stepped forward and pulled out a folder from underneath their arm. Tomura neatly plucked out a stapled sheaf of papers. He turned around to Izuku and held them up for him to see.

Dread began to sink like an anchor inside Izuku when familiarity came knocking.

Tomura threw the papers to the ground in front of Izuku.

“You haven’t been married for an entire goddamn *month*,” Tomura hissed.

Izuku’s eyes latched onto the page lying askew near his knees. His heart dropped, plummeting straight into hell when he recognized his own signature. It was still familiar in its rushed curvature, but now grotesque in its betrayal. But more horrifyingly, sitting right next to it was Katsuki’s signature—forged, in perfectly neat black ink. The decree of legal separation burned on the page:

The Official Divorce of Bakugou Katsuki and Mamushi Izuku.

Finalized.

The font was bold, bureaucratic, and merciless.

Bile surged up to scald his throat as a memory roared to the surface.

Tomura had briefly asked about the divorce papers the night of the masquerade—but Izuku had dismissed it. Foolishly. *Stupidly*. He should have known better because Tomura never asked questions without reason. Every inquiry was a chess move. Every word he spoke was a trap.

Izuku shook his head and cried through the gag. He screamed out ‘no’ as loud as he could as his heart broke further and further.

Katsuki was staring in horror at all the papers messily tossed on the ground. His gaze was fixed on his faked signature, shoulders trembling with the slow realization of what had been forcefully taken from them.

Their eyes met, and Izuku’s skin went cold.

Katsuki’s face was ashen in resignation, as if he accepted what was coming.

Tomura turned to Katsuki then, cocked his gun and his subzero aura descended further.

Izuku began struggling. He kicked, he screamed, he tried to get away from the two large men holding his arms. He thrash so hard past the paralyzer to the point the men restraining him needed to force him to the ground. Izuku screamed into the gag as his chin hit the dirt and his belly pressed into the cold snow.

He shook his head as Tomura lifted up his gun and pointed directly at Katsuki.

Katsuki’s throat bobbed. He glanced at Izuku and then to Tomura. He tried his best to not show fear. But it snuck out through a single tear and a trembling lip.

“Don’t cry,” Katsuki called to him. Izuku’s screams turned his throat raw as Katsuki nodded as if everything was going to be okay. His ex-husband’s nostrils flared as he took a deep breath, never letting go of his gaze. “I told you—even in death, Izuku. I’ll claw my way back to you again and ag—”

The shot cracked through the air and the world split in two.

Izuku’s scream broke his vocal cords at the same time the bullet tore through Katsuki’s abdomen. Blood sprayed from the wound in a cruel, vivid arc.

Blood, so much blood, rained across the snow as Katsuki choked. His eyes went wide and his body toppled backwards into the coffin behind him with a sickening thud. He hit the wood while his groans of agony gurgled in his throat, wet and raw and unfinished.

Before Izuku could process the sight, the Vipers picked up the lid of the coffin. They slammed it over Katsuki and sealed in his howls of pain.

“Nail him in tightly,” Tomura instructed, unfazed. “Chisaki has specific orders that he’s buried alive. The heir wants him to suffer in agony up until his last breath.”

Izuku sobbed helplessly into the cold dirt as they began.

Nail after nail, Katsuki was hammered into his final resting place. Izuku began shaking his head as he heard the wood splinter from the sheer force the pounding was done with. With every nail in the coffin, Izuku’s heart broke further and further.

Unkindly, the Vipers dragged the heavy coffin over to the grave. They tossed it in with a clumsy thud and Izuku broke down more. Wrecked cries ripped through his throat as he listened to the sound of dirt being piled on top of the coffin. With every layer, Katsuki's groans of pain grew more distant.

And when his siblings were done, they packed in the soil tightly, making it look like a perfectly well deserved grave. Izuku sobbed helplessly.

Tomura rolled his shoulders and put his gun away. He pulled out a needle of paralyzer that glinted against the snow. He grabbed Izuku roughly by the arm and sunk the needle in slowly.

Limply, Izuku hung there. His limbs were useless as he hung his head low. He choked on his own sadness as he was suffocated by the weight of what his brother had done. Tomura began to drag him over, directly on top of the grave. When he stopped, he reached down to grab Izuku by his chin and forced his head up.

Izuku's heart shattered into irreversible pieces when he came face to face with the headstone.

The name Bakugou Katsuki stood directly in front of him.

"Take a good look," Tomura demanded. "I want you to understand what your defiance has cost you."

Izuku's soul broke.

Tomura straightened, then threw Izuku over his shoulder like he weighed nothing. All the fight had been stripped away from Izuku's bones. He couldn't move. He couldn't struggle. He hung like a rag doll as he was carried away. His paralyzed body swayed with every step, but his eyes never blinked.

The Vipers and Yakuza fell into step behind Tomura, a silent procession of monsters. And together they began the slow march away from the grave.

As he watched the headstone grow further and further away, a light inside of him died. It was smothered, directly by the hands of his merciless brother. He knew it then. He knew this part of him could not be reignited. It could not be reclaimed.

Because all his life, he had denied it.

He knew this was a risky path.

He knew they had a slim chance.

But he just didn't know how much it truly would cost them.

Because Katsuki was always his tempting forbidden fruit. In Izuku's eyes, he was the ruinous apple that damned the entire human race, but he took that bite anyway. He indulged himself in the fantasy of what could've been in hopes of a better future. However, he should've known better than to give in to the illusion that a sinner like him could be worthy of love.

But still, he took that bite. And inside of that apple was a dose of venom strong enough to kill them both.

Chapter End Notes

Welp. :') Katsuki POV time!! Yay? 😃 I hope you enjoy and please let me know what you think below—

locks my doors

Chapter 38: Confuoco

Chapter Summary

> Confuoco (Instrumental tone) — to play with fire

Chapter Notes

> Helloooo!!! First, omg the response to the last chapter was insane!! Thank you ALL so much for reading and leaving your reactions! I was giggling like a madman reading all the comments, theories and screams. I think that was the biggest reaction ever a chapter has gotten :') thank you! I had a busy last two weeks so I haven't gotten the chance to reply to everyone but I'll get around to responding like I usually do <3
>
> Now, without further delay, big thank you to Luna, the LOML, for betaing and proof reading like always!! She does such a good job with giving me feedback and always pushing me to be better :')
>
> Enjoy! <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes



Chapter 38 — Confuoco

.

.

.

Two And A Half Months Earlier

The dormant darkness inside of Katsuki viciously snarled and snapped its sharp teeth. The entity melted with the part of him that loved Izuku so deeply. Clashing emotions melded into one, truly testing the thin line between love and hate, until his darkness became a gigantic beast too overwhelming for him to contain.

Katsuki gripped the folder until his fingers tore through it and his nails pierced his skin.

His palms bled all over the photos, dark red pooled over Izuku's face. Drip by drip his thick blood soaked the photo and it gave him pause. He studied how Izuku's face was drowned in red. The same way his mother's had been.

All roads led to Izuku.

As Katsuki stared at the photograph, his darkness and the part of him that loved Izuku agreed on one thing: **devour him.**

Katsuki's two sides hummed in agreement as his eyes restricted.

While half his brain contemplated mariticide, the other was drowning in hurt so profound he didn't know how to process it. Because *why*? Why would Izuku, who loved him, do this? How *dare* he?

How fucking *dare* Izuku drop this bomb and think he could waltz on with his goddamn life?

Did Izuku think he was disposable? Some trivial chapter, now neatly closed? Or worse—had Katsuki never mattered to the man? Had all those affectionate glances and caring touches been a lie?

His gaze caught on the photograph of his mother. Her smile had been captured mid-laugh, radiant and blinding in the stillness of film. It hurt to look at her. But it hurt more to look away. Because beneath that smile was a graveyard of grief Katsuki buried but never properly mourned. And now Izuku unearthed it. Fucking ripped it out of the ground and left him holding the bones.

Katsuki shook where he stood, trembling so hard his teeth ground together. His heart caved in on itself, collapsing under the weight of the twisted, unspeakable truth in his hands.

The love of his life killed his mother.

An ugly, wretched sob slipped from his lips. Katsuki felt painfully alone.

He craved warmth, a hug specifically. But he was disgusted with himself when the one person who he wanted the hug from was also the person who had inflicted this irreversible pain.

It was here Katsuki felt it again: that horrible loneliness that followed him his whole life. It cut into him and took up room, pushing his cruel self deprecating thoughts that have haunted him since childhood to the surface.

“You’ll never be good enough to be loved,” his self hatred hissed. “Of course he left you here alone to deal with this. Your feelings don’t matter.”

“The last four months were nothing but a lie,” his self-doubt murmured. “There’s no one on this planet that could love a monster like you.”

“Even if he did love you, he left,” his anxiety muttered. “You were never that special to him.”

More tears poured down as he glared at the photograph of Izuku. He felt the distance between them stretch and it broke his heart. How the fuck was this happening? The *one* person he thought he had finally formed an intimate connection with was gone. And had killed his *mother*. And quite possibly, fucking knew this *whole time*.

His anger flared, fusing with his sadness.

Katsuki’s darkness snarled one more time and kicked him into gear.

His eyes snapped up and he violently slammed the folder on the table. He clenched his fists as he stormed back to the bedroom. He knew what he had to do. He deserved to know what happened to his mother straight from the mouth of the assassin. If he had to stalk Izuku to the ends of the goddamn earth, then so be it.

The paralyzer in his blood was lessening with every furious step he took. It vanished as he threw on his clothes, boots, and motorcycle jacket. His mind was like a giant buzzing hornet’s nest as he grabbed for the keys. He threw several clothes into a duffle bag, hastily packing and not paying attention to what he was grabbing.

Then his eyes cut down to his left hand.

The tiny green gem taunted him.

His rage immediately screamed ‘throw it away’. Just as he was about to snatch it off his finger—he stopped.

Without warning, the part of him that loved Izuku surged forward.

He clenched his teeth as he was torn in two. Deep down, he didn’t want to take the ring off. He was in denial, grieving the love he thought they had fostered.

He didn’t want to accept that Izuku would hurt him like this.

But moreover, a tiny voice in his head was worried about Izuku’s safety.

The ugly truth of Izuku being trafficked was like acid in his mouth. He couldn’t shake how Izuku reacted whenever it was mentioned: the smaller man would clam up, his eyes would skate to the side and he would curl into himself.

It all added up as signs of *severe* abuse.

That damn Izuku could barely utter a word about his upbringing. And because of that, Katsuki pictured it must be the worst living conditions imaginable. For all he knew, Izuku was trapped right now. Probably locked up in a cage like an animal.

Then Katsuki hesitated.

What if Izuku didn't choose to kill his mother? What if he was forced?

But just as quickly, the dark part of him—furious, betrayed—snarled back: don't make excuses and don't be fucking weak. It snapped its teeth at the side of him that loved Izuku.

Katsuki closed his eyes to gain composure when he felt himself slipping. The two halves of him began to detach from each other, and they became at odds. His darkness wanted retribution. But the side of him that loved Izuku wanted answers.

His heart began to split—and it was the worst heartbreak Katsuki ever experienced. But there was one thing that made sense to both sides: find Izuku.

He grabbed his bag and walked out the door towards the train.

In the end, the ring stayed. But so did his fury and so did his heartache.

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki arrived at his apartment in Yokohama by sunrise.

His steps were like drums. Loud, furious, and daring to pulverize everything in his way. He didn't say a word to his doorman as he stalked up to his unit. Immediately, he knew where to go.

He ripped the hall closet open and dropped to a crouch. With a snarl, he shoved aside the heavy trunk full of firearms and its metal surface scraped the wood. His hands went straight for the floor. One by one, he tore up the loose boards, ignoring the splinters that bit into his fingers.

Patiently waiting for him underneath was his tracking gear.

The black briefcase radiated death. It was a collection of all the specialized electronics he only used if he was truly hunting a ghost. He picked it up, blew off the layer of dust, and clutched it tightly.

He walked up to his dining room, sat down, and snapped open the latches.

Each device sat in its cutout like an instrument on a surgeon's tray.

Hundreds of tiny, black trackers sat next to his portable hacking deck, signal interceptor, and GPS signal sniffer. He inspected his old signal blocker and customized tracking laptop.

Particularly his laptop he made sure was still good. Over the course of the last ten years, Katsuki took it upon himself to learn coding. He had made from scratch several programs that gave him the upper hand when hunting.

Luckily for him, everything was still in top notch shape.

It had been a couple years since he had to pull this stuff out. Last time, the bastard he was after fled two prefectures and burned every bridge. He nearly got away. But that was the keyword: nearly. Katsuki always was able to track a mark down. There wasn't a person on this planet who could get away from him.

Especially not his goddamn husband.

☽ ☽ ☽

Down in the garage, he stalked straight to slot four. The tarp covering his motorcycle hung heavy like a shroud. He tore it off in one, furious motion.

The scarlet chassis gleamed beneath the overhead lights, sleek and blood-bright. Twin black lines slashed down the frame like war paint. The matching helmet dangled from the handlebar like it had been waiting for him.

He put on his helmet and straddled his bike.

As he put it in gear, he already knew where to start.

The memory of the tall, silver skyscraper complex came to his mind. He could still perfectly picture Izuku walking inside, being swallowed by those large double doors. The sigil was seared in his memory: two snakes intertwining on a V.

Without a second thought, Katsuki sped off into the morning light towards Hadeus, Tokyo.

☽ ☽ ☽

It took a while to find it. The narrow, crooked path Izuku had led him towards all those months ago was not easy to locate.

It was like Hadeus only opened its jaws to a select few. Those it did not want, it chewed up and spit back out. But Katsuki eventually tracked it down, like he did with everything.

Hadeus was marked by the faint smear of blood on the sidewalk that stretched into a narrow alley. He drove carefully down the dark street. And the longer he did, the bumpier the path became—screaming how unwelcome he was.

Exactly like four months ago, it was like entering the Bermuda triangle.

Every trace of normalcy faded. Corner stores vanished, replaced by shuttered fronts and gang-owned stalls. The pedestrians changed too. No office workers or tourists. Only restless men and women with heavy jackets and heavier stares. A few leaned against cracked walls, counting yen or lighting cigarettes.

Their eyes were sharp and unblinking as Katsuki passed.

Neon signs flickered above them in colors too harsh to be warm. The colors bled blue and violet into the street, casting long eerie shadows. From somewhere close, laughter burst out loud and sharp. But it was the kind that didn't sound too friendly.

He kept riding, scanning for the cluster of skyscrapers burned into his memory.

But Hadeus was bigger than he recalled. It was a labyrinth of smoke, steel, and concrete. Hundreds of people milled about. Some hawked at sizzling, savory street food. Others tucked into corners under the bass thrum of music spilling from broken windows. Clubs with blacked-out glass pulsed with life like open wounds.

The road tightened, choked by bodies and sound.

As Katsuki went further in, a man with an eye patch watched him too long—much like a predator weighing the kill. Katsuki gripped his throttle tighter. Suddenly, he understood why Aizawa had warned them about this damn place.

Right as Katsuki was beginning to think he messed up the location, he saw it: the twin viper sigil.

Exactly like he remembered, it sat on top of gleaming glass double doors.

As he drew near, Katsuki slowed his bike. He parked it around the corner, hidden in the shadows. He took off his helmet, and the wind blew through his hair. He looked up, studying each floor of the silver building as it stretched into the dark fog above him.

Then, the doors opened.

His heart pulsed.

Out walked two people. One man, one woman. They were dressed all in black with dark colored hair. In their hands were briefcases but what caught Katsuki's attention were their eyes.

Sitting inside of their stares was a chilling, vacant hollowness.

It perfectly matched Izuku's photo tucked inside the red folder.

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki found a tall, grimy hotel wedged beside the Viper Academy.

It was the kind of place that reeked of desperation and sketchy deals. Instead of regular people who needed a place to spend the night, shady business exchanges were clearly running.

He passed by one group of women smoking in the hallway. They leered at him, scrutinizing him in case he was trouble. Then another group of people looked over their shoulders,

skittish. And another pair of men didn't even bother to glance at him, but there was blood caked on their faces and murder dancing in their eyes.

All of this made Katsuki feel right at home. No one would bat an eye at him coming and going for the next few days.

He paid cash and requested the room he scoped out. It had a clear view of The Viper Academy's front entrance. From there, he could watch every single bastard who came or went.

When he opened the door to his room, the smell of mildew greeted him. Next, the scent of stale cigarettes wafted all around. He noticed how the grey wallpaper peeled at the corners and how the overhead light flickered like a dying insect. The mattress sagged in the middle and there was a weird, questionable stain on the carpet.

But all Katsuki cared about was the single grimy window that overlooked the street below.

He pulled the rickety coffee table to the window and began to set up. He positioned his heavy duty laptop on the surface and neatly laid out all his guns, ammo, and high tech devices. With a soft grunt, Katsuki grabbed the wobbly wooden chair in the room and sat down.

He peaked out the curtains of the window and glanced down below.

☽ ☽ ☽

First Week of Separation

Katsuki barely slept. Not because he didn't want to, but because whenever he fell asleep he was greeted by the same, horrible lucid nightmare involving his mother.

It started like a true dream. He was back in his mother's apartment, smiling and laughing with her. He could feel the way her small hands cupped his face and how she would halfway hug him. He could smell the lingering perfume as she walked across the room to prepare dinner while making snide remarks.

Then when she turned around, she was smiling as blood trickled down her temple from a gunshot wound.

He would spring up and try to grab her, horrified as her eyes rolled back. But he was held in place by Yakuza goons stronger than him.

He whipped his head to the side and there, he could see Chisaki. The Yakuza Heir's cold, golden stare cut into Katsuki ruthlessly. While behind him, Izuku lurked in his shadows. His lover's green gaze was no longer sweet or docile. It was mercilessly sharp as he held up the smoking gun to his lips and gave it a venomous kiss.

Then like clockwork, Katsuki would wake up choking on his own breath, drenched in sweat.

After three dreams like that, Katsuki put all his efforts into hacking into The Viper Academy's system.

He wasn't as good as Denki. The annoying Pikachu probably could hijack the system in less than eight hours if given the right motivation. But what Katsuki lacked in knowledge, he made up for in sheer, blazing spite and black coffee.

While his fingers coded on auto pilot, his thoughts slowed up. The cloud of hurt and anger gave way to logic ever so slightly.

He couldn't help but wonder why Izuku left so abruptly. It didn't make any damn sense.

Red folder aside, Katsuki assumed Izuku would make one more attempt to sever their marriage before he departed. The nerd had made it abundantly clear that he wanted a divorce. But instead, Izuku just left. He didn't even leave behind so much as a cell phone number or divorce papers so they could get their accidental matrimony sorted out.

It was…odd. Concerning, really, if he was being truthful.

So Katsuki made the only conclusion he could: someone else interfered and dragged Izuku back before they could close out. Whoever it was must've then told Izuku that he was the true killer of Bakugou Mitsuki, and Izuku left abruptly right after finding out.

Because even though Katsuki was angry, he felt as if that would make sense for Izuku's character.

He could see the sensitive man's bleeding heart dosed in shame. And because of that, Izuku likely departed without a fight. It made sense that he would go back to a place that treated him so terribly if he was too ashamed to properly ask for help.

And because of that, Katsuki's concern for Izuku's safety was sitting at the front of his mind. He could imagine shadow hands dragging the smaller man into a cage. However, despite this imagery, the longer he staked out The Viper Academy, Katsuki noticed two strange things.

First, Izuku was nowhere in sight.

The second, the people coming and going came back every single time.

Over the course of several days, he watched people buzz about the building. Some of them he began to recognize. They would dress in different outfits such as casual jeans, or formal blazers, or even stealth suits meant for assignments. But a lot of them talked and got food like normal people. They wandered around Hadeus like it was a regular neighborhood and laughed with the other shady locals as if they were completely free.

It was really bizarre. Because if these people were like Izuku—sold into human trafficking—why the hell did they look so content? But more importantly, why did they go back every time?

He couldn't quite figure it out.

Suddenly, his laptop dinged.

His hands ceased typing as a pop up window appeared on his screen. Staring back at him was the disabled firewall for The Viper Academy's network.

He swallowed hard. Then his mind flooded with visions of Izuku.

He leaned in, and began to scroll through all the folders inside. Some things were still heavily encrypted. Like clientele info and agent records. He also curiously saw a heavily guarded folder entitled 'Mamushi Venom: Failed Mithridatism Experiments.'

But luckily for him the alarm for the back gate was accessible.

He set an automatic alarm and code on his laptop for 02:00am. When the clock struck at that exact time, his software would temporarily disarm the back gate for one hour. That was long enough for him to slip through, get inside, and find Izuku without needing to poke the hornets' nest.

As he tried his best to rest up, the two emotions inside of him were clashing. They were fighting over what to do when he actually found Izuku. His darkness wanted blood but his love wanted clarity.

The more the night bled away, his love won out.

It was tipped over by looking at his phone.

His lock screen was still Izuku. It was that stupid, cute photo of the man feeding a deer at the same time a small butterfly landed on his nose. His rage wanted him to change it to a blank, black screen. But his love was winning out the more and more he thought of Izuku being somewhere alone and frightened.

For the rest of the night, Katsuki idly scrolled through the four months worth of photos of Izuku smiling on his phone.

☽ ☽ ☽

Breaking in didn't go as planned.

Turns out, the Vipers have more than just a firewall, they had fucking armed guards waiting inside.

It took all but two steps into the courtyard for shit to hit the fan. Katsuki was spotted within seconds and shot at. Luckily for him, he was quick on his feet. He ducked out of the garage before it could slam shut again and sped off on his motorcycle.

He clenched his teeth as the guards kept on his tail in hot pursuit. They poured into large black SUVs, chasing him quickly. He bobbed and ducked as bullets whizzed past his helmet and skinned his jacket.

He twisted his throttle, weaving through Tokyo's backstreets at neck breaking speed.

☽ ☽ ☽

After he shook them, Katsuki decided to follow his better judgement and leave his motorcycle elsewhere. He found an isolated garage in the next district over. It was dressed in blackness and completely out of reach of CCTV.

From there, he trekked back to Hadeus on foot in different clothing he bought on the fly.

He kept his head down, jaw clenched so tight it ached. When gangsters passed too close or let their gaze linger a second too long, he pulled the brim of his baseball cap low, shrouding his face in shadows. As he walked, every bass drop from the blacked-out clubs made his blood throb in sync. It was like Hadeus itself was mocking him—pulsing with life while he felt like he was bleeding out inside.

By the time he reached his hotel room, his head felt like it was going to explode.

He shut the door behind him and collapsed into the chair by his workstation.

For a moment, he just sat there. His chest rose and fell like a storm, barely holding it together.

Then, he snapped.

“Fuck!” he roared, hurling his cap across the room. It hit the wall with a dull thud and slid down.

He clawed his hands through his hair and gripped the roots. He shakily breathed as he dropped his head forward. Then he bent low in the chair, elbows on his knees, fingers laced behind his neck as though trying to hold himself together with pressure alone.

His failure tasted like ash.

It choked him. The bitter reality of not knowing what was going on made him unwillingly imagine it. His mind toggled between sweet Izuku locked in some nightmarish chamber and then his mother. He felt her blood, her smile, and her deathly silence.

His breath came in shallow pulls.

Katsuki shook his head hard, like he could knock the pain loose from his skull. Then slowly, he straightened. He forced the tremor out of his hands, and stared at his laptop’s screen.

There had to be another way in. And he was going to tear that whole place apart until he fucking found it.

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki pressed his laptop keys smoothly as he slipped past another firewall.

He took a slow, large gulp of his black coffee. His eyes were bloodshot from lack of sleep as he dived deeper and deeper into The Viper Academy’s system.

It was here he found that within The Viper Academy halls were hundreds of wire taps. They all funneled into the main system, likely feeding audio to whoever was in charge. Katsuki

thought it was disgusting. But he supposed in a place like that, of course the walls had ears. No one sold there probably ever had a shred of damn privacy.

His anger bristled on Izuku's behalf.

He listened for a full day to various conversations. Most were casual. A lot were about assignments and killing. But many of the conversations confused Katsuki. Because how the fuck did these people seem so calm? Weren't they being held against their will?

Then finally Katsuki caught a conversation that was useful.

"Himiko!" A voice of a man said. The grainy vocals frayed through Katsuki's computer as he tried to stabilize the signal. "Hey! Do you happen to know where Izuku is? I wanted to ask him something about venom altercation. We're running more Mamushi Venom trials."

"Sorry," A sharp voice of a woman replied. She sounded like she couldn't give less of a damn. "You're shit out of luck. The runt isn't here."

"Really? I thought he was back from Bangkok by now."

"He is. But Tomura moved him out of the compound."

"Ah, that sucks. Do you know where Tomura moved him to?"

"I do, but I'm not supposed to tell."

The conversation then faded, buried underneath static.

Katsuki's heart skipped a beat and then his stomach knotted.

He recognized the name Tomura. Izuku had mentioned it during their time in Biei, specifically when he had the breakdown at the mere sight of a belt. In that small window, Katsuki learned the older brother who relentlessly abused Izuku was named Tomura—and now that bastard had taken him somewhere.

He wearily looked out the window again towards the building.

☽ ☽ ☽

Second Week of Separation

Izuku wasn't at The Viper Academy. That dead end slammed Katsuki right back to square fucking zero.

No leads, no trail. Just static in his ears and fury in his gut. He spent hours hunched over the wiretaps strung through the hallways, listening for anything—anything—that could point him in the right direction. But he got nothing. There was not a single goddamn hint about where Izuku had been moved to by Tomura.

Katsuki only had one, real choice left. He had to go on foot, wandering around Hadeus.

He felt like he was searching for a ghost. Around every corner he saw a memory of Izuku. Chuckling. Smiling. Clutching his book against his chest. Katsuki searched in every restaurant, alley and building that he came across. But each time he thought he saw Izuku—it turned out it wasn't.

He circled past one of those loud obnoxious clubs again, but this time he was cut off.

Suddenly, a wall of bodies formed in front of him. Katsuki looked up from underneath his baseball cap and narrowed his eyes. In front of him were three men and one lethal looking woman.

She stood at the center, posture relaxed but commanding. A cigarette was tucked behind her ear and brass knuckles gleamed on both of her well manicured hands.

The men flanked her like obedient hounds on a leash.

One was thin and jittery. He was flicking a switch knife open and close with trembling hands. Another was a hulking mass of muscle, his face marked by a crooked nose and an eyebrow piercing. Then the last man, silent and cunning, hovered behind her. He was watching Katsuki with deadly intent as he kept his hands behind his back—likely on a gun.

Katsuki didn't move. And neither did they.

Then finally, the woman broke the silence with a soft, dangerous smile.

"What's your name, blondie?" she asked, voice slow like molasses. "I've seen you creeping around my club the last couple of days."

Katsuki tore into her with a vicious glare. "Don't worry about it."

"I'm afraid I'm gonna have to," she replied. One look was all it took for her hounds of men to take a step forward and show their guns. They pointed them straight at Katsuki's heart, knees, and head. "Let's try this again, shall we? You've been extremely suspicious peaking into my VIP section. You don't even say a word before you turn and leave. Did someone send you as a spy from Dragon's side?"

"I have no idea who Dragon is," Katsuki replied calmly, not fazed by the weapons. "I'm only looking for someone. I don't want trouble."

The burly man spoke up. "Who are you looking for then if you're not a spy?"

Katsuki groaned. This is why he fucking hated gangsters. They were the most jumpy goddamn people on this planet.

With careful movements, Katsuki decided to take out his phone. He turned his device around for them to see his lock screen of Izuku.

"I'm looking for him," Katsuki explained. "Have you seen this guy? I really need to talk to him."

All four gangsters exchanged looks, then broke out into loud, crazy laughter.

Katsuki frowned. What the hell was so funny?

The jittery one doubled over like it was the best joke he'd heard all week. Even the silent one cracked a grin. The woman flicked her hand again, and the guns vanished as quickly as they'd come. Now they were looking at Katsuki like he was some poor sap who'd wandered into the wrong alley.

"You and half of Hadeus are looking for that pretty thing," the woman said with a shake of her head.

Katsuki's eyes narrowed. "What is that supposed to mean?"

"You heard me, lover boy," she teased pointedly. "You're not the only one running behind that Viper for a bite. You might as well get in line."

Suddenly, another gangster from the shadows arose. Katsuki didn't even notice him at first. He was shorter in stature and gripping a long knife. He must have been keeping watch in case Katsuki was trouble. But now he joined in like he wanted a slice of the gossip.

"Who's he lookin' for?" The short man asked curiously.

"You'll never guess," the jittery man snickered. "*Viridian*!"

The short guy covered his mouth in pure humor and shook his head at him.

"Another poor soul smitten by the green eyed gem of Hadeus," the woman chuckled. "I don't blame you. I'm also hoping for a shot one day. Maybe in our dreams we'll all get lucky."

"It's not like that," Katsuki hissed, suddenly feeling very possessive. "I actually know him."

"Sure you do," the big one said with patronizing sympathy. "Look, you might as well give it up. Izuku is polite, but he's not going to give you the time of day. He doesn't go out with anyone. Trust me, I've been trying to fuck him for the last five years. He's as prude as they come."

"Well, I heard he's shacked up with the Yakuza Heir," the short man said casually. "They're probably kissin' and grindin' as we speak."

White noise cut through Katsuki's ears.

"…What the hell did you just say?" He turned to the man, voice sharp like a blade.

"Chisaki Kai," the man clarified like it was obvious. "I heard from a friend of a friend that they're havin' some sort of courtship. A lot of people who work for Chisaki are vouching for it too. They're all sayin' Chisaki basically put the word out that no one is allowed to touch Izuku besides him—and he doesn't say things like that lightly. They might be half way into a honeymoon stage by now."

“Ugh, of course,” the woman sighed. “Makes sense someone like Izuku would wind up with a Yakuza. Power and beauty. Tale as old as time.”

Katsuki’s pulse roared in his ears.

“Bullshit,” he growled, immediately rejecting the concept. “There’s no way in hell that’s possible.”

“Oh, it’s possible,” the short man doubled down. “Look, maybe you can find Viridian down below. He tends to run errands for his brother in the circles pretty frequently.”

Katsuki hesitated. “What do you mean…down below?”

“In the real Hadeus,” the man replied, watching the growing confusion on Katsuki’s face. “Oh, you’re kidding me right? You’ve never been to the circles before?”

“No,” Katsuki replied, fully guarded.

The jittery one pointed across the street, toward a thumping blacked-out club.

“Go in there and go towards the back,” he instructed sinisterly. “There’ll be an entrance and the code word to get in is ‘Inferno’. Maybe you’ll find Izuku and he can tell you straight up he’s not interested.”

They all laughed again and began to walk away.

“Good luck, lover boy,” the woman called over her shoulder, waving as the group turned and walked off, grinning.

☽ ☽ ☽

Against his better judgement, he followed the instructions. Every nerve in his body was screaming for him to turn around because this was clearly a trap. But his mind was stuck on Izuku. Specifically what those extras said about Izuku and Chisaki.

It had to be bullshit. Pure, trashy gossip people tossed around for sport.

Still, the words bothered Katsuki.

When he got to the back of the humid club, he was met with four large body guards with mean sneers. He didn’t look them in the eye as he spoke the password. It was the key to a lock, and immediately one of the guards stepped aside. He pulled back the velvety curtain for Katsuki and it was as if Hadeus finally opened its jaws.

Katsuki walked past all its sharp teeth and found an elevator. A herd of people were busy coming and going on it and it took him a while to push inside. There was only one, black button. He pressed it and the elevator doors clanged and swallowed him whole.

Down, down, down the throat he went.

The air got colder, denser, and more sour with every moment of descent. As he stood in the packed elevator, Katsuki couldn't shake the sensation that this was bad news.

When the elevator reached the bottom, it was like he was spat into the underworld.

Enormous black pillars rose up around him, sleek as obsidian.

They vanished into the ceiling so high it didn't seem real. Bridges hung between the pillars like suspended veins, carrying foot traffic over balconies and into buildings that jutted from the concrete like tumors. Everything here was cast in shadows and neon lights. Crimson, plum and indigo illuminated from all over, making the three colors blend together like they would in a bruise.

People roughly shoved past him when he didn't move, but Katsuki couldn't if he tried. He was too shocked.

He'd heard the phrase 'Tokyo's underground scene' tossed around before, sure. That meant sleazy bars, clubs too exclusive for the public, and places people only found if they knew the right kind of scum.

But this—

This wasn't a metaphor.

Hadeus was a real city—no. It was a machine with a million moving parts.

The air down here reeked of liquor, sweat, and something metallic. Blood, most likely. People were shouting over thumping bass, and he could see men and women in stilettos with glassy eyes selling pleasure with a smile. Woven between them were gangsters in suits grinning too wide. And smoke curled from cigarettes like fingers wrapping around all of their throats.

Katsuki swallowed when all his alarms went off.

☽ ☽ ☽

As he descended, he learned that the first level he had been on was just the beginning.

There were nine levels total, each representing a different theme.

It was like Hadeus was Tokyo's wicked twin. It was a perfect reflection inverted and warped until all that was beautiful was tainted by malice. Hundreds of bodies moved around him, brushing past like insects, vibrating with noise, energy and hunger.

The First Circle was called Limbo.

It stretched wide and open, a network of half-formed buildings and alleyways. It hummed with low-grade desperation. Shady types crawled through the dim streets, looking lost or hunting for a gang to claim them. The buildings served as halfway sanctuaries. He learned

these places were where people could crash for the night without too many questions. Or stash something quick and dirty before disappearing into the dark.

The Second Circle, Lust, hit Katsuki like a backhand to the face.

As he walked downward, the lights changed. Fuchsia and red bled across the walls like smears of neon blood. It was a red-light district, and it was thriving. The architecture mimicked the vastness of the circle above. But the energy was louder here. Shameless and truly damn hungry. Alluring men and women leaned out of doorways, beckoning with painted nails and sleepy eyes. Brothels, strip dens, and underground sex clubs tempted anyone who walked by.

The glow in the Third Circle, Gluttony, was sickly.

Green lights with yellow flickers that danced like chemical flames. This was the stomach of Hadeus, and it churned. The streets were lined with illegal restaurants that had black-market chefs selling dishes that were banned topside. The air reeked of grease, smoke, and something acrid and sweet. There were booths tucked into corners, peddling banned drugs without shame.

But even after searching in every crack there, Katsuki somehow thought the Fourth Circle, Greed, was worse.

It screamed a type of capitalism Katsuki always detested. Greed lived here in the open, unashamed and weaponized. Gambling dens stretched as far as the eye could see, and every corner had a loan shark smiling with too many teeth. People in sharp suits traded dirty money like playing cards. He learned every square foot belonged to someone who had bought it with blood or leverage.

He bitterly thought about how much his mother would love it in this circle, specifically.

The Fifth Circle, Anger, was smaller than the last four. It narrowed ever so slightly and his cell phone signal gave out.

Down here, Katsuki noticed the bustling noise faded.

Instead, the air simmered with rage. Underground fighting rings were everywhere, pitting people against each other in cages. Some bare-knuckled. Others held sharpened blades. It didn't take much for Katsuki to realize blood was currency here. Graffiti covered the walls, and every individual looked seconds away from swinging. Even the air tasted of violence as people placed bids on who they thought would be the winner.

The Sixth Circle, Hersey, made Katsuki's skin feel cold.

Not physically. But his bones recognized the shift. It was sterile, quiet, and more dangerous and narrower than Anger. This level was carved from doctrine and ideology. Radical groups holed up in glass-and-metal buildings. They preached dangerous truths or outright goddamn lies to anyone who lingered long enough to listen. There were cults, self-help movements

twisted beyond recognition, and even sanctuaries of scientists so deep in their theories they abandoned humanity altogether.

The Seventh Circle, Violence, reeked of rot.

This was violence in its purest form. Not brawls or grudges—no. This was calculated cruelty. Human trafficking routes. Torture bunkers. Every room Katsuki passed in this level left screams unanswered. This was the worst of what humanity had to offer. As he searched for Izuku, he found many buildings down in this smaller circle were locked or blocked off.

Katsuki wandered here the most. He was worried sick that Izuku was trapped inside one of those locked rooms. But like the other six circles, he couldn't find him. So he continued his journey down.

The Eighth Circle, Fraud, sickened his stomach.

Everyone here was a damn liar, and that was the only honest thing about it. Counterfeiters, con artists, and blackmailers lined the streets. Paperwork traded hands faster than blades. Identities were for sale as people started over with entirely new names and lives.

Katsuki sighed as he finished searching every inch of the Eighth Circle.

His eyes looked up at the long row of swaying red lanterns above his head. They lined a narrow passageway of buildings that was packed with skittish people. Light chatter was all around him as flickering red, orange, and purple neon signs written in kanji flickered on and off.

Katsuki squatted down on the concrete doorstep of one building. Above him, a neon sign for a secret pub hummed softly.

He stared solemnly at his lock screen of Izuku. His heart twisted in a terrible way. In every single circle, Katsuki showed Izuku's picture around in hopes that someone knew where he was.

He felt really fucking pathetic, like a kid passing around a flyer of their beloved lost animal. It was demeaning. And it only added to his growing frustration because every time someone did recognize Izuku—they laughed him off. Or Shrugged. Or even tried to ask him where'd he gotten the picture and if he could fucking air drop it to them.

But worse, he just found more people emphasizing that rumor about Izuku and Chisaki.

"They're totally in love," one old gangster said with a shrug. "I heard from the Yakuza themselves that Chisaki is planning to sweep Viridian off his feet and keep him for himself."

A sex worker also confirmed the same thing. "I've heard that Chisaki is already planning to woo him with some grand gesture. You might as well cut your losses. Once Chisaki has his sights set on someone, they're as good as his."

"My friend swore she saw them kissing in one of the lounges in the third circle about five months ago," a drunk man had snickered. "They're probably together."

And those were just some of the confirmations that stood out amongst many.

Katsuki shook his head when his anger started to overpower his love for Izuku. He had not a clue what the fuck was going on. But he decided he didn't believe it. Not unless he saw it for his damn self he wasn't going to believe those disgusting rumors.

He picked himself up and began to work his way down to the very last circle, Treachery.

When he approached the last, concrete stairway, cold air spilled from down below. He shivered as the wintry breeze touched him and gritted his teeth when ominous eyes crawled on his skin.

As he walked down the dark staircase, he noticed the distinct lack of people. No drunken beggars. No sex workers. No music and no liveliness like up above.

But he did notice the few people here were sharper looking. Meaner and gruffer. They all donned katanas on their backs, tattoos and a symbol of a geometric flower somewhere on them. Katsuki narrowed his eyes at the sigil. He didn't recognize it, but it was pinned on every single person's black blazers.

As he approached the entrance for the Ninth Circle, a row of thick body guards stopped him.

"Sorry you can't go down there," a large, built woman barked at him. She leered down at him with the meanest snarl Katsuki ever seen.

Katsuki frowned and glared at her. "Why not?"

"Ninth circle is reserved for Shie Hassaikai personnel only," she stated. "Now, beat it."

Katsuki frowned deeper. Then goosebumps raced down his spine. His killer instincts heightened and he carefully glanced over his shoulder. There, he could see every eye on the staircase was on him. They were all suspiciously sizing him up with their hands on their guns and swords.

It was easy to conclude everyone surrounding him was a scummy Yakuza. Which meant that the geometric flower pin they were all wearing was the Shie Hassaikai symbol.

Katsuki backed up slowly, deciding poking this nest would be suicidal. When he was on top of the concrete stairs, he took one more glance down at the hidden level.

A pull in his gut told him that he would be back.

☽ ☽ ☽

When Katsuki made it back to his motel room, his eyes were bloodshot. The veins inside of them were spidering through the white like wildfire, inflamed and angry. He knew he looked wrecked but he honestly felt worse.

Sleep was clawing at him now, begging to drag him under after days of running on fumes. His skull throbbed with a migraine that felt like someone jammed a knife through the base of

it and twisted. But none of that mattered. All he could think about was Izuku—and fucking Chisaki.

The image of them together sent a violent heat through his chest. His jealousy flared so fast and savage it made his teeth clench. But beneath the fury, his gut was twisting with doubt.

It didn't sit right.

Izuku was a romantic. Hell, he'd waited to have his first time with the right person. He was the kind of idiot who blushed at Hallmark movies and cried during the sappy wedding scenes. His Izuku wouldn't fall for men like Chisaki. He wouldn't touch filth like that, let alone smile at them.

And yet, everyone in Hadeus that knew Izuku seemed to think otherwise. It was like these people knew an entirely different version of Izuku—one that Katsuki had never seen.

He worried as he sat on the edge of the bed.

He went digging into his duffel, meaning to grab the red folder. But instead, his fingers caught on a thick red fabric. He frowned in confusion and held it up. Katsuki exhaled roughly, bitterly laughing almost.

In his furious packing haze, he had accidentally grabbed the bright, scarlet red suit he bought with Izuku. He remembered how Izuku told him he looked good in red, cheeks pink and eyes full of love. Resentfully, Katsuki shoved the suit aside and pushed the memory down where it couldn't hurt him.

He clutched the red folder with shaking hands.

The paper inside was wrinkled now, bent at the corners from being handled too many times. Still, he opened it again, forcing his tired eyes to read every damn word. He wanted to find some kind of inconsistency. Something that screamed forgery or a trick. But the deeper he read, the colder his blood ran.

There was nothing but the truth here.

With every new detail Katsuki forced himself to absorb, it was proven this is what actually happened to his mother. He saw the absurd dollar amount The Viper Academy had been paid —and the percentage that was Izuku's personal cut. Chisaki even listed things about her that only someone who stalked her would know. Much like the red folders Katsuki would be handed before his own assignments.

He even learned his mother had been with the Chisaki family during that winter she abandoned him. She sought refuge in a Yakuza safe house, took out a loan of about a million yen to get back on her feet, then fled without repaying her debts. She even stole some pearls from Chisaki's grandmother.

Katsuki's stomach twisted. That sounded very much like his mother.

Now it made sense what happened back then. He always wondered how they were able to afford a whole new apartment and car after she had disappeared for an entire year.

But worse, there was a small, italicized sentence at the bottom of one paragraph: *Overhaul formally agrees to have Stain take the credit for the murder for optics purposes.*

That sentence alone felt like it confirmed all his nightmares. He discerned that Overhaul must've been Chisaki's code name. Same for Stain for Chizome for whatever reason.

His eyes caught the glint of the small green gem on his finger. He began to toy with the ring, spinning it back and forth on his finger, trying not to crumble.

"Why did you leave me like this, Izuku?" Katsuki muttered sadly.

And in the silence that followed, not even the walls had an answer.

☽ ☽ ☽

Over the course of the week, Katsuki prowled the underground circles of Hadeus like a ghost chasing an echo.

He slipped through the alleys, clubs, and bars again and again and again. Somehow, word got around fast amongst some of the low-level gangsters. The cruel minded people started calling him Lover Boy in a half-mocking, half-pitying way. They were beyond amused, enjoying watching a man unravel in real time.

Katsuki had now spent two weeks in Tokyo—and he had jack shit to show for it.

No matter how many networks he hacked or hushed conversations he leaned into, nothing pointed to Izuku. It was like chasing smoke with his bare hands.

Izuku's legal names only came up twice: once on his death certificate as Midoriya Izuku at the age of two. Then another time, Mamushi Izuku came up with their marriage certificate. The proof of their union was floating in the public Nago, Okinawa wedding registry. But that was all any digital database gave about Izuku.

There was no phone number. No email. There weren't even medical records. Not even a whisper of the Mamushi surname was in government databases or public files.

It was like Izuku never existed.

Currently, he was lying in bed. His head was pounding as he poorly attempted to rest his eyes. To his side on the coffee table was his laptop. He decided to keep an open line on The Viper Academy's wiretaps in case something of interest popped up.

"Damn, you look beat," the deep voice of a man chuckled.

"I am," a woman groaned. She sighed loudly and her voice picked up static through the receiver. "My back is killing me from the assignment I just finished. Do you think you can

buy the grocery for Izuku and Katsuma tomorrow morning before we go see them so I can sleep in?"

Katsuki sprung upright and looked at his laptop with wide eyes.

"Yeah, no problem. What time did you want to head out tomorrow to drop off the food?"

"Probably around eight a.m. so we can be there by nine. Oh. By the way, are you going to the masquerade ball Chisaki is throwing for him and Izuku's coming out? It's Saturday."

"Mhm, Tomura is making me," the man grumbled, seemingly unhappy. "He wants extra muscle there in case something goes wrong. I told him I think he's being paranoid but he seems worried."

"That's just Tomura. You know how he gets about Izuku. He asked me to come too and make sure everything goes smoothly."

"Damn, this Izuku and Chisaki getting together is a real big deal, huh?"

"It is!" The woman said cheerily. "Ah. I'm so excited. I still can't believe Izuku caught the Yakuza Heir's eye. That's such a big accomplishment!"

The conversation fizzled out with static, moving elsewhere.

Katsuki scrambled over to his laptop, and immediately tried to fine tune his software to continue listening. But found nothing but static cutting into him. The two agents must have moved behind closed doors where there were no wiretaps.

He stared with confused, hurt eyes at his screen.

Katsuki's breath came out in short, jagged huffs. His pain and anger began to swell as he processed what he just heard.

He glanced at the dark, scarlet tux carelessly tossed on the back of a chair in a new light.

☽ ☽ ☽

Third Week of Separation

When the morning came, Katsuki checked out of his motel room.

He went and got his bike before sunrise, and stationed himself a good healthy distance from The Viper Academy. He clutched his binoculars as he kept an eye out for a man bringing in groceries.

Then he saw him. The tall man walked like he constantly had some smooth jazz music looped in his head. He was dark blond and in the middle of his forehead was a strange, perfectly vertical scar. And in his arms, he hauled along a healthy heap of groceries.

The guy didn't see Katsuki as he walked in The Viper Academy. Then he didn't see Katsuki again when he exited with a green haired woman through the back.

The two rode off in a bright, electric blue sports' car towards the highway.

Katsuki's resolve to get to Izuku deepened. With bloodshot eyes, Katsuki pulled his helmet down over his head. The visor clicked into place with a hiss, muffling his uneven breathing. Then the engine roared back to life beneath him.

He kicked off the curb and tore into the street like a bullet chasing its mark.

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki eased back on the throttle as the car far ahead of him veered off the main road. It disappeared into a winding, tree choked path that cut into a private area. He spun around on his bike and began to discreetly circle the perimeter to look for another way in.

He drove around until he found a proper vantage point. It was far enough to not be spotted through the thick layer of trees, but close enough where he could still see.

From here, he spotted a giant ocean side mansion. It was embedded into the side of a cliff and appeared more marvelous than anything Katsuki had ever seen. These were the types of houses he would drive by and wonder how in the hell did someone ever afford such property.

With a grunt, he sat down behind a row of bushes and pulled out his binoculars.

He scoped out the scene, and found several armed guards with rifles circling like hawks. But when he lifted up and looked to the rooftop—his heart stopped.

Through the lens he recognized the shape of Izuku.

He was getting out of a pool that was stationed on the rooftop.

Izuku rose from the water like the enchanting creature he was, hair flipping back as droplets sprayed all over. Ribbons of water rolled down his defined back muscles and v-cut abdomen as he hoisted himself up with a brilliantly bright smile. His hands pushed back his bouncy, wet curls as he began to dry off with a towel.

Katsuki slowly peeled the binoculars away from his face. He blinked.

This wasn't at all what he thought he would find when he finally located Izuku.

He imagined Izuku in the basement of some shady warehouse, being forced against his will to do unspeakable things. But instead, he found this.

For the rest of that day, Katsuki observed.

He was originally doing this to get a feel on the guards' patrol patterns so he could sneak inside. But instead he found himself gawking at what he was witnessing through the windows.

Katsuki was baffled.

The whole day Izuku was happily smiling, playing with a small child. The boy had light brown eyes and hair with a smile that resembled Izuku's. Katsuki assumed this must have been the child, Katsuma, that Izuku mentioned that he needed to get out.

But neither of them looked scared. They looked peaceful as they ran around the mansion playing tag.

Izuku and the small child played hide and seek outside, ate healthy, and watched TV on the biggest screen Katsuki had ever seen. Even more so, the clothes they were dressed in were expensive. He recognized the name brand logo that was stitched into the black sweater above Izuku's heart. That shirt alone cost roughly 140,000 yen.

He even saw Izuku quietly hand wash a dark green Rolls-Royce Phantom Oribe in the driveway. The way he was attentive to the rims made Katsuki guess the car was Izuku's. This was confirmed when he saw the license plate said 'Viridian'.

Something unpleasant tugged at Katsuki.

It was rooted in shame for how impoverished he grew up.

When they were kids, he always considered there was a possibility that Izuku was extremely well off. The fact Izuku was able to steal money without being noticed alluded that whoever was raising him was rich enough to not miss a few dollars.

This was completely opposite of how Katsuki grew up. Katsuki was raised dirt poor, struggling from the bottom to keep his head above water.

But here Izuku was with no chains, no gun to his head, and wealthy beyond comprehension. It looked like he was here, willingly. Happily far away from Katsuki and all his brokenness.

"He knows you're from the gutter," his self hatred hissed. "Why would anyone that wealthy want to lower themselves to your level? Of course he doesn't love trash like you."

"The problem is you," his self-doubt murmured. "You were not a good enough person for him to stay."

"Even if he does love you, he left," his anxiety muttered. "He chose to be far away from you."

With a heavy heart, Katsuki continued to observe Izuku.

☽ ☽ ☽

The next two days, Katsuki camped out at his vantage point in the cold.

He shivered in his sleeping-bag as he waited for an opening to get inside of Izuku's home.

But it was hard. The armed guards that circled the mansion barely took a break. It was like they were wind up robots. They were more efficient than anything Katsuki had ever seen. They didn't slack off for a single second and that made it almost impossible to get close to the mansion without tripping alarms.

While he waited for an opening, Katsuki watched Izuku through the large glass windows.

During these two days, Izuku frequently checked his phone. Katsuki grew sadder. He wondered why Izuku hadn't even bothered to leave him his phone number. Did he really never plan to talk to Katsuki again? It seemed like it. Izuku lazed around the mansion watching TV and reading books out loud to Katsuma.

It was as if the four months they spent together didn't happen.

From the looks of it, Izuku had really moved on with his life. He didn't seem to give a single damn about the wreckage he left Katsuki in.

Seeing Izuku so relaxed and well taken care of fed into the hurt inside of Katsuki's chest. And when his hurt grew—so did his anger. The two were so attached for him, and the passage between them was the same tunnel inside of Katsuki's heart.

Then on the third night, Katsuki saw something he didn't think was possible: one of the guards slipped up.

Someone showed up late for their shift, leaving the back window and patio entirely unguarded.

Immediately, he sprung up from his sleeping bag and dusted the dead leaves off his body. It was late at night, and he could see Izuku in his usual spot on the couch watching something on TV.

Masking himself in the dark of the night, Katsuki bled into the shadows. He crept up quietly, jumping over the fence in the back and landing expertly on his feet. His sharp eyes homed in on Izuku who hadn't seen anything, too distracted by something in his hands.

Using the tree line, Katsuki crept closer to the house. He carefully scanned for cameras, and was happy there were none in the backyard. Then when Katsuki crouched low in a bush by the window, he froze. At this angle, he finally got a view of the TV—and it was playing their wedding video.

"I promise to always come back to you, darling," the Katsuki on the screen said drunkenly.

Katsuki's heart skipped a beat.

Izuku was playing their wedding video? The tiny fragments of his love for Izuku pieced together then. His heart fluttered in a dangerous way, going against all the hurt that was stacking up inside of him.

Katsuki crept closer. He got near enough to gaze from behind Izuku.

And in Izuku's hands was a photograph.

It was of them, wearing flower crowns and laying on the grass. They had cheesy grins on their face and the look in both of their eyes seemed so hopeful. Izuku lightly traced Katsuki's smile with his fingers.

So much affection was pouring out from those lovely, green eyes.

His love for Izuku pushed his anger out of the way and gripped the wheel. It held on tightly as he walked up to the window without thinking. He looked closer now, and that's when he noticed what he couldn't see from so far away: Izuku was sad.

Depression was pouring off of Izuku in waves as he comforted himself with the memories of Katsuki.

Katsuki's heart pulled. His intuition began screaming: something was deeply wrong. Why did Izuku look like he was on the verge of crying?

Too deep in his thoughts, Katsuki didn't see Katsuma until it was too late.

He heard a tiny gasp close to the glass.

His eyes snapped down.

At his feet was Katsuma. The small boy's knees were on the floor in front of the window while he watched Katsuki like a damn horror movie. He gaped up at Katsuki like he was Godzilla incarnate with horrified eyes. A plastic toy car dropped from his little hand and clattered on the wooden floorboards with a clink.

Katsuki froze. Blinked. Then muttered, "Shit."

The kid didn't move. Neither did Katsuki. They stared at each other for a second, locked in a mutual what-the-hell moment. Thinking fast—or not thinking at all—Katsuki forced a smile. He lifted a hand and gave the world's most awkward wave.

The kid screamed.

"Oh, what the fuck—" Katsuki hissed under his breath, nearly tripping over his own feet as he staggered backwards.

He ungracefully ducked into the bushes and shrouded himself in the shadows. Leaves whipped at his face and a large branch smacked him square in the forehead. He hastily scrambled away because he was sure that shrill yell would alert the guards from the front.

And he was right. Quickly, two of the guards with rifles came around the corner like hounds, sniffing around for the source of the sound.

Katsuki hid as best he could in the darkness, and sweat began to profusely gather on his brow. Through the branches of the thick bushes, he could see Izuku in the window cradling and comforting the small child.

Izuku was armed now, gun in his hand as he tightly held the boy up with his other arm.

The guards scanned for a moment, eyes glowing with deadly intent. Then when they didn't find anything, they went back to their stations.

Izuku, however, didn't move.

He stayed by the window, squinting into the darkness.

Then, as Izuku glanced over the yard, his eyes landed on Katsuki's location. Unwillingly, Katsuki's heart kicked up. He wondered if Izuku could see him, but when Izuku turned around after a prolonged moment, he knew he couldn't.

The guards began their patrols on the back side of the mansion again, this time, doubled up.

Katsuki's frustration burned when he realized he couldn't get close again.

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki didn't get another opening.

He had wanted to get in before Saturday, which was officially tomorrow. If what that man and woman said was true, then Izuku would be meeting up with Chisaki somewhere for some sort of masquerade event.

His palms were beginning to itch to get his grasps on Izuku because something was off with this whole damn thing. There was no way in hell Izuku was with Chisaki. Maybe Chisaki is the one who threatened Izuku to leave. He must've informed Izuku about the red folder as well.

That had to be the only explanation for it all.

But still—it bothered Katsuki how peaceful Izuku seemed in the house.

Izuku was on his phone so much that Katsuki couldn't help but wonder why the man didn't bother to leave his number. This is where while he loved Izuku, he knew his hurt was right. Something wasn't adding up, but Izuku still discarded him.

One of the small threads holding on to giving Izuku the benefit of the doubt broke at that moment.

It was clear, Izuku wasn't being held against his will. He just didn't want to see him. Now, two more threads hung in the balance. The first, Izuku was not with Chisaki. The second, Izuku couldn't have known at any point that he was the one who killed his mother.

He came to the conclusion he just needed to ask one question: how long did you know?

Because if what he thought was true, the answer would be, "I found out from Chisaki and left, because I was so ashamed."

And Katsuki truly believed that would be the answer.

☽ ☽ ☽

Night of the Scarlet Masquerade

When the next night fell, Katsuki changed into the red suit he'd stashed in his bag. He armed himself with his holster discreetly under the blazer with multiple guns. He wasn't taking any chances if he was going to be surrounded by Yakuza tonight.

He dusted off the dirt and leaves clinging to him from the last few days of camping out in a goddamn sleeping bag. His spine cracked as he stood. He stretched out the ache and a heavy sigh left his chest.

He was deep fucking in it for Izuku.

All his life, Katsuki never thought he would be in this position. But here he was, so in love with Izuku he was sure he'd walk through hell for him. He had fallen so hard in love he was sure he broke something in his brain when he landed. Had this been anybody else, he would've simply collected their goddamn life for what happened to his mother.

But for Izuku—Katsuki's love for the man rivaled his need for vengeance.

The two beasts were deadlocked in an ultimate tug of war of strength. Each grew stronger when fed in the slightest. And right now, his love was winning after seeing Izuku gazing so longingly at their wedding video.

His love was reaching out, telling Izuku to hold on and that he was coming.

Katsuki put on his motorcycle jacket and zipped it tight. He rolled his shoulders, pulled on his gloves, and wheeled his motorcycle around the front. With extreme sleuth, Katsuki hid well in the shadows of the trees. He watched as the gates opened, and pouring in came a long line of unmarked black cars.

At least ten vehicles drove up in front of the mansion in perfect unison. Each was freshly washed with shined golden rims. In the middle of the cluster of cars was a long, expensive limo. The side was embellished with a golden sigil of the Shie Hassaikai.

His anger simmered at the sight of that symbol.

From this distance, Katsuki couldn't see Izuku or the man he was standing with well. But he saw them climb in the limo and he saw the long string of cars drive back the way they came. The winds blew loudly as if they were pushing Katsuki to follow them.

His fingers curled around his helmet. He slid it on once more, clicked the visor down, and straddled his bike.

The engine growled to life beneath him.

☽ ☽ ☽

When he got to the venue, it was the most disgusting show of wealth Katsuki had seen in a while.

He'd always held contempt for the ultra wealthy. Especially those who wasted money.

This kind of decadence, where fortunes were pissed away on champagne fountains and designer silk worn for a single night, made his skin crawl. There were people starving in alleys while these bastards drowned themselves in caviar and top-shelf liquor just to feel something. He hated them. All of them.

And he was unhappily conflicted to learn Izuku was technically one of these people.

The ballroom venue had bright, green lights illuminating the whole structure. The marble architecture of the building had old renaissance angels engraved into it. And hundreds of people Katsuki recognized from the underground scene were walking about in masquerade attire.

He frowned deeply the longer he scanned some of the poorly hidden faces.

Most of these people were Yakuza, easy to spot under the fancy clothes with sleeves of ink creeping from under cuffs. The Shie Hassaikai insignia was either stamped like a brand on their flesh, stitched into their lapels, or sewn in gold thread across their tailored collars.

He slowed up amongst the thick crowd of cars. He eased into the line of black luxury vehicles, idling a few cars behind Izuku's limo.

When the sleek vehicle stopped, everyone by the entrance turned, awaiting.

Katsuki watched Yakuza bodyguards pour out the limo.

Then a man whose hair was as white as crushed bones got out. Katsuki frowned when he caught sight of the viper tattoos that filled his neck. The dark ink perfectly matched the frostbitten deadness in his eye. He seemed familiar but Katsuki couldn't place from where in his sleep deprived haze.

Following him, Chisaki got out of the limo. His golden eyes were sharp and apathetic, much like a king too comfortable in his power. He didn't even bother to hide the way he surveyed the crowd, like he could buy them all with a snap of his fingers.

Then slowly, Izuku emerged.

Katsuki's heart slammed once, *hard*, as if trying to break through his chest to reach Izuku.

Izuku shone like a true, precious gem. It was like he sparkled under all the lights.

His shirt was black, high collar, and made of lace that clung to his freckled skin. The material held an intricate pattern of vipers woven in and out of the design. At his collar was a dark green necktie that was a shade of viridian so deep it nearly blended in with the black color of the lace. To match it was a pair of sleek black slacks, a formal black blazer, and a viridian pocket square that matched the neck tie.

And on his delicate face sat a beautiful masquerade mask that enhanced his eyes.

Gorgeous emeralds shone under the light. They were embedded into the sides of the mask, lining the cut out for his eyes. Falling from the bottom of the mask were strings of emeralds beaded together into tassels.

His handsome appearance stunned several people around him. All eyes were on him, only for him.

From here, Katsuki could see Chisaki hold his arm out for Izuku.

The world stilled. The bright lights grew dim, the people in the crowd faded away. All of Katsuki's senses focused on what happened next.

Izuku fluidly slid his hand into the crook of Chisaki's arm and smiled sweetly up at him.

And in that moment, Katsuki's heart ripped straight down the middle in a clean, catastrophic break.

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki parked his motorcycle in the shadows, tucked it, his jacket and his bags out of sight a couple buildings down and made his move.

With easy effort, he climbed the back wall that was facing away from the crowd. He pulled himself up hand over hand like he had done many times before on assignments. He skillfully shuffled across a small ledge as the early winter winds began to howl at him like a warning. His fingers burned against the cold stone but all he could see in his mind was Izuku smiling at Chisaki.

He reached the third floor and saw an open window.

Carefully, he inched over to it and hoisted himself inside. With heightened agility, Katsuki lowered himself into the room. His sharp eyes scanned the area and noticed it was entirely empty. Then he cursed under his breath when he heard movement coming towards him from the connecting room.

"Man, I'm so excited for vacation this year," a man chuckled. "I'm just happy we can catch a break this winter—"

Katsuki tried to hide, but there was nowhere to go. Three large Yakuza men dressed all in black with porcelain masquerade masks walked straight into the room. They spotted him immediately.

Shit.

"Hey—you!" One shouted. "No sneaking in!"

That was all they managed before chaos broke loose.

The three guards bum rushed him at the same time he dove forward. Katsuki let his fists fly. He ducked a wild swing and slammed his knuckles into the first man's gut. The second reached for a knife—too slow. Katsuki cracked him across the jaw and pivoted, breath ragged with fury.

He wasn't leaving without talking to Izuku. Especially not after what he'd seen outside.

The image of Izuku on Chisaki's arm burned behind his eyelids. It stroked his inner darkness and turned his movements sharp and savage.

Katsuki began to go toe to toe with the three guards, sucker punching them and side stepping quickly. He was quick on his feet, deciding he had *enough* of this bullshit. He was getting to Izuku tonight one way or another, goddamnit.

His rage boiled over in that moment, egged on by the hurt in his heart. He took his blade out of its holster and sunk it into the side of one man's neck. Then he gutted another man with the thought of his mother.

In a twisted dance, he whirled and quickly disarmed the last guard of his gun. The man grunted as he tried to punch Katsuki in the head—but Katsuki was stronger and quicker. He took the barrel of the gun, pointed it to the man's heart, and pulled the trigger.

The silencer on the pistol made the deadly bullet quiet.

The man choked out in shock and dropped to the ground.

Katsuki stared down with brazen hatred. He enjoyed the way the Shie Hassaikai symbols on their blazers were tainted in red.

As he took in the three dead bodies, Katsuki decided it was okay. If he needed a more direct approach to get to Izuku—then so be it. A few Yakuza scum dying in the grand scheme of things wasn't an issue to him.

He squatted down low and noticed one of the porcelain masks the guards was wearing was cracked, shattered on the ground. He picked it up slowly, noticing small droplets of blood splattered across. Katsuki glowered when he realized he did in fact need a mask in order to not stand out.

With an exhausted sigh, Katsuki hooked the broken mask to his face.

Next, Katsuki dragged the bodies to a closet off to the side. He hoisted them in, with blood dragging across the carpet. As he stacked the bodies, all he thought of was his mother, probably watching him.

He felt her grin, happy that Yakuza had lost their life just like she had lost hers.

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki searched for Izuku. High and low. Far and wide. He pushed through countless people searching for that pop of dark green. He wandered down to the ballroom floor, weaving

between all the people dancing around like they were in a fairytale.

Then when the dancing slowed, and the crowd began to look up, Katsuki did too.

Katsuki saw him the moment he stepped on to the top of the stairs.

He was dazzling, and his whole appearance commanded every lick of attention in the room. Katsuki's heart skipped a beat and it was like the floor dropped out from beneath his feet. His ribs caved in around his lungs, making time stutter and bleed out between heartbeats.

Through the haze of crystal chandelier light in the crowded room, stood Izuku.

And he was holding hands with Chisaki.

Suddenly, Katsuki didn't move. He couldn't.

For the first time since he saw his mother's dead body, he was really paralyzed. His body was ice wrapped in searing fire, every one of his nerves lit up and burned as he watched the scene unfold with the slow-motion cruelty of a dream gone wrong.

He observed from a distance as Izuku and Chisaki slowly descended the spiral stairs. They made their way to the center of the ballroom, their eyes never leaving the other's. They began to flow together with the rest of the lavish crowd, looking at each other like no one else existed.

The orchestra wailed its song like a beast in heat.

Strings thrashed against silence, percussion pounded out a rhythm that sounded more like a countdown than music. And across the polished marble, under velvet drapes and golden chandeliers, Izuku began dancing—with *him*.

Chisaki's gloved hand rested low on Izuku's back, the other wrapped tightly around his fingers, holding him how Katsuki used to. And Izuku—*god*, Izuku—didn't look scared. He didn't look alarmed. He looked calm. He looked like he'd chosen to be there.

Katsuki could feel heat swelling under his skin.

It boiled through his veins, curling his fingers into fists so tight his knuckles turned white.

Every part of him screamed to lunge forward.

He wanted to fucking tear Chisaki apart with his bare hands and drag Izuku away to Biei. He wanted to demand answers, demand the truth, demand fucking *everything*—but he stayed still. His soul was paralyzed by the brokenness that was riddled across his body.

His chest was collapsing with every step Izuku and Chisaki took in their dance, and it felt like they were stomping all over his wounded heart.

Their bodies moved as one, perfectly in sync with the music's violent rise and fall. They twirled through the golden room like they were truly betrothed. Chisaki caressed his skin.

Their eyes connected. Their breaths were in tandem in a way that Katsuki thought was only meant for him.

The longer he watched, the more his breath turned to smoke behind the mask. His inhales became progressively more jagged and his heart began pounding in his ears.

Chisaki's hand slid a little lower.

And then it happened.

Chisaki leaned in. His mask brushed Izuku's freckled cheek—and he kissed Izuku.

It was a kiss meant to be seen. And see—Katsuki fucking *did*. The kiss was a flat out show as if Chisaki was screaming from the rooftops to everyone: look what I got.

Katsuki waited for any hint of disgust on Izuku's face. A wrinkle—or even a curled fist.

But instead, he saw Izuku slowly kiss back. He saw the way Izuku's damn eyes fluttered closed and the way his hand pulled Chisaki closer. Katsuki saw the way the kiss lingered and deepened just long enough to be consensual.

The second thread holding on to giving Izuku the benefit of the doubt snapped.

The orchestra reached its crescendo at the same time jealousy so violent gripped Katsuki's core. Violins shrieked like sirens over blood-soaked streets, and Katsuki stood there in the middle of a masquerade that might as well have been his funeral, watching his world collapse.

No one around him seemed to notice the way his jaw was clenched so tight he could barely breathe. No one noticed the way his hands trembled at his sides, nails digging deep enough to break skin. No one noticed the fact that a man who had lost everything was now watching the person he had given his heart to be revealed to be someone else's.

"Ah, aren't they such a handsome couple?" Some man beside him said.

A woman hummed in agreement. "I think they're a perfect match. No one better for each other."

His darkness pushed aside his love for Izuku and gripped the wheel. It made itself back at home in his body, taking control with the power of jealousy so hot Katsuki thought he might melt through the earth's crust.

Two of Chisaki's henchmen walked up to them right as they were about to kiss again. The Yakuza Heir departed with his goons, leaving Izuku alone in the middle of the floor. The crowd went back to dancing, paying him no mind. They twirled around, creating a busy scene.

Katsuki stepped forward like he was beckoned. His eyes narrowed and all he could see and feel was green.

He roughly pushed through the dense dancing crowd to get to Izuku.

Then Izuku quickly turned on his feet. He walked off to the corner.

Katsuki's darkness rumbled in his chest as Izuku retreated from the crowd. He tipped his chin low as he approached. Izuku leaned his side against a large pillar in the back with his head down. He closed his eyes as Katsuki circled him like a shark.

His heart hammered loudly as he came up behind the smaller man.

Then when he got close enough to smell that sweet cologne, Katsuki's logic tipped right off the deep end.

He reached a hand out, and did what was within his right. He clasped his fingers around Izuku's throat and pulled his damn husband back to him—where he belonged.

When Izuku collided against his chest, Katsuki's lungs expanded with both satisfaction and rage.

"I found you, darling," he hissed into Izuku's ear.

His husband stiffened. Visible goosebumps raised along his skin as he craned his neck.

The moment those beautiful green eyes latched on to him, Katsuki felt his emotions grow stronger. His love for Izuku leapt, overjoyed to be reunited. But his anger was screaming bloody murder over what the fuck he just saw.

But between those two beasts was his logic. It was keeping a curbed leash on both, barely holding on.

"K-Katsuki?" Izuku whispered in disbelief. His eyes began to stretch wide. "You—You're here?"

"I am," Katsuki answered curtly with a tilted head.

Izuku didn't reply. He gawked at Katsuki like he was a ghost who shouldn't be here.

Something about Izuku's confusion was progressively pissing him off. He felt that fury in his chest screech once more. He tried to calm down but it was impossible. Katsuki seethed as he waited for Izuku to fucking say *something*.

Izuku glanced at the people on the dance floor.

When Katsuki followed his line of sight, he noticed Izuku was gazing after where Chisaki had left off. His nostrils flared. Izuku was thinking about Chisaki at a time like this?

Izuku turned around slowly and Katsuki loosened his grip. He dropped his hand to his side and Izuku cut his eyes down the vacant hallway around the corner. Suddenly, Izuku grabbed Katsuki's wrist.

“We can’t be seen together here,” Izuku whispered hastily. He jutted his head to the side where the hallway was. “Let’s go over here.”

Izuku tugged on Katsuki’s wrist and tried to lead them away.

But Katsuki stayed like a rock. He was offended that Izuku was trying to usher him into the shadows like some goddamn side piece. His insecurities raked their claws down his insides, and he suddenly felt deeply unlovable.

Izuku looked back towards him with a questionable glance. He pulled again, but was unfruitful. Izuku nervously gazed up at the stairs once more for Chisaki, and Katsuki felt that ugly jealousy pulse.

“K-Katsuki, seriously,” Izuku warned with heightened urgency. His eyes darted at all the people dancing about. “We—we can talk but not here. We can’t be seen together right now.”

“Since when was it a crime to be seen with your *husband*?” Katsuki asked carefully, with a slight bite.

Izuku halted.

“Husband?” Izuku parroted. He looked at Katsuki sideways. “We’re…We’re still married?”

Katsuki glowered. What the actual fuck?

“Of course we are,” Katsuki hissed.

Izuku looked visibly confused, and genuinely displeased about the fact they were still married. Suddenly, Katsuki’s anger rumbled again. This time, louder in his throat. The look Izuku was giving him was pretty much screaming: I don’t want to be married to you.

Izuku let go of his wrist and took a hurtful step back.

Both his anger and love told him to take a step forward.

“Why don’t we have a dance, darling?” Katsuki asked, trying to keep a lid on his barely contained emotions.

He gestured behind him to the open floor. He didn’t want to be tucked away. He wanted to be claimed, openly, and prove to himself once and for all he could be loved. Maybe Izuku could find him offering a dance to be romantic, and the love of his life will be reminded of their time together.

That sad part of him was still holding on to his love for Izuku, hoping Izuku was still holding on back.

“I’ve always wanted to dance with you properly,” Katsuki added honestly.

He held out a hand for Izuku to take.

But Izuku continued to stare at him sideways—and it felt like a stab to the heart. Izuku glanced up at the stairs once more, and Katsuki tried to push back the wrathful tears in his eyes. Izuku had checked not once, but *thrice* for his real lover because he was clearly hesitant to be seen with Katsuki.

Suddenly, now it made more sense why Izuku was so insistent upon the divorce. It wasn't because he thought it was for the best—it was because he had someone else waiting on him. Someone who had given Izuku the goddamn green light to kill his mother.

Izuku then reached for Katsuki's hand.

Immediately their fingers laced together, and Katsuki decided he was going to tear the answers out of him.

Izuku tripped a bit as Katsuki pulled him close. Slowly, Katsuki began to backtrack to the center of the floor. Out of spite, he stopped at the exact spot where Izuku was moments ago with Chisaki. He hoped it would make Izuku feel guilty for double timing him in a way. Sure, they never fucking said they were an item—but the love in his chest believed that Izuku was his and he was Izuku's.

In the dense dancing crowd, Katsuki began a fast paced tango, the only genre of dance he knew.

They kept their gazes tethered as they swayed, pulling close. The rush of body heat and intimacy blossomed between them as they locked stealthy, cat-like steps. They whirled, not breaking eye contact and then Katsuki dipped Izuku low, almost to the ground.

Katsuki's logic held the leashes tighter on his two beasts as he tried his best to keep a leveled head.

When his emotions stopped holding him hostage, he finally asked the one question that would decide everything, "Did you know all along you were the one who killed my mother, Izuku?"

Izuku stumbled in his dance steps.

At this proximity, Katsuki could feel how his husband's heart raced faster. Much like a liar's would.

"No," Izuku answered. "I didn't know the whole time—"

"—Then how long *did* you know?" Katsuki asked, cutting straight to the point.

As he thought more about his mother, Katsuki's anger began winning the battle against love. It made him pick up the pace in their dance. He was now making sharp movements hard enough to make them both dizzy. Everything immediately blurred in a blend of bland colors as they were whipped around and around.

"I found out the night you went to retire," Izuku whispered.

At this, Katsuki's fury paused.

The very last thread of an excuse he gave Izuku was gone, snapped in two.

"You knew for the entire last *month* we were living together?" Katsuki whispered in disbelief. "And you didn't think to tell me?"

He slowed their dance and all the blurred surroundings came back into focus. Izuku looked around, dazed and dizzy, eyes cutting once more to the stairs searching for Chisaki.

True hurt spread across Katsuki's heart. It stuck so deep that Katsuki was unsure it would ever leave.

"I…I was going to. B-But I was too afraid," Izuku confessed.

His beautiful eyes became glossy and true, remorse shone through. But Katsuki couldn't feel it. Everything from the last three weeks was stinging him like thorns. All this time he had given Izuku the benefit of the doubt. And he was wrong.

Izuku continued his speech, and Katsuki grew angrier.

"I wanted to," Izuku said. "*I did*—I couldn't find a way to come out and say it. I'm so sorry, Katsuki. I'm really *really* sorry for everything. If I could take back what I did, I would. I didn't know it was her. I-I swear. I know that doesn't excuse anything."

The wall of hurt around Katsuki transformed into steel as he relived the last month they lived together.

He saw them dancing, sweetly singing to each other. He saw Izuku cuddling by his side and kissing his sternum. But worse, he saw Izuku sit in front of his mother's goddamn grave and say he loved Katsuki.

Indignation struck like a hammer.

"You're right," Katsuki hissed, and his darkness begged to be let free as his hurt grew and grew. "You're pathetic sorrys don't excuse anything. Why didn't you just fucking tell me instead of letting me believe it was Chizome?"

"Because I was scared of hurting you," Izuku admitted in a small voice.

Katsuki's raw expression twisted with a snarl. His chin lowered menacingly and the mask on his face nearly slipped off.

"Bullshit," Katsuki snapped. "Bull fucking shit. If you cared about hurting me, you wouldn't have had that *scum's* tongue down your throat five seconds ago and who knows however many times now."

Izuku's eyes widened, but no denials came. This time, Katsuki wasn't waiting around for Izuku to give him more pathetic ass sorrys.

“Now. Let’s try that again. Why did you not tell me, Izuku?” Katsuki demanded.

“Because I was scared,” Izuku whispered, holding back tears. “That’s the truth.”

“But of *what*?” Katsuki demanded, raising his voice.

At the sharp volume, Izuku flinched. And immediately Katsuki stopped dancing all together.

With that single flinch, a revelation dawned on Katsuki.

His menacing scowl fell to the ground. In its place was only the look of a sad, misunderstood boy. Katsuki silently stared at Izuku in disbelief as it all clicked together. Their last month together flashed before his eyes and this time, it was tainted.

Suddenly the voices of his self hatred became crystal clear.

“You were scared…of *me*,” Katsuki whispered, voice low and full of pain. “Did you think I would hurt you if you told me? Even after everything?” he asked, softer now, the question hanging like a broken limb.

Silence followed.

Izuku opened his mouth, then closed it.

Katsuki slowly leaned away, shocked at the lack of denial.

His eyes darted all around Izuku’s beautiful face that he adored so much. He waited for a moment. Hoping that there would be some sort of hint that Izuku wasn’t scared of him. But there was none. Soon, Izuku’s prolonged silence was enough of an answer.

And that answer was, “Yes, Kacchan. I am terrified of you. I always have been.”

Katsuki’s features crumbled inward like a dying star the longer the silence stretched on. He saw the boy Izuku used to be, with the eye patch. He saw that small Izuku who he wanted to protect quivering away from him, crying and fearful to touch him. Katsuki’s eyes started to burn and his tears pushed forward.

This whole time, Izuku had lied.

He didn’t think Katsuki was soft at all. He didn’t think Katsuki could be kind, or gentle, or worthy of love. Izuku was just like everyone else, frightened of Katsuki’s hands and damaged mind. He was scared of the anger Katsuki wielded to shield himself from the jaws of a world that kept trying to eat him alive.

And here Katsuki was, stupid enough to believe he could be anything but the son of a fucking monster.

He had gotten his hopes up all because a boy with pretty green eyes told him he could be soft. All this time. All those nights. All those goddamn hours he spent trying to be better—it was

for nothing. He thought Izuku saw him. Not a monster, but the person he was trying to become.

But the truth was out in the open now: Katsuki was a monster to everyone, even the man he loved.

And that is all he would ever be.

Katsuki's hurt morphed into something truly fearsome in that moment.

It grew winged armor, fangs, and shrouded itself in the anger Katsuki always used to protect himself. A single tear drop fell out of Katsuki's eye and took all his reasoning with it. In its wake, the tear left behind a dark leer crafted of violent jealousy and depravity.

"No," Izuku said suddenly. But it was too late. He began shaking his head furiously but Katsuki knew the truth now. Izuku was a damn liar. "No. No, Katsuki. I-I'm so sorry I didn't think that at all—"

"—You did," Katsuki said in a deep, steady voice. More tears fell. "You're scared of me. Because I'm a *monster*, right?"

Katsuki's eyes darkened and his wall of anger shot up to new heights.

His eyes narrowed as his pupils constricted down into tiny dots. All that was left in his eyes was an unnatural amount of scarlet.

"You were scared enough to poison me so I wouldn't be able to hurt you," Katsuki reasoned, finally seeing the truth plain as day. With every accusatory word he spoke, hate gathered in his tone like a tsunami. "And then you came running to Tokyo for protection from me in Yakuza scum's arms. But worse of all, you went and cuddled up with the man who requested my mother's murder without a goddamn shred of decency."

Katsuki's hold on Izuku grew more and more intense.

"No," Izuku exclaimed past his wincing. "N-No! That's not what this is at all. I told you in my—"

Izuku yelped out loud when Katsuki's fingernails tore through the material of his blazer. The sharp tips sunk into his skin, drawing blood. Izuku tried to move backwards away from Katsuki. But it was no use. Katsuki's grip was as strong as an iron fist.

He decided then and there, Izuku was going to pay for lying and killing his mother. And so was that fucking Chisaki.

Katsuki's jealousy roared to life and snapped the leash off his darkness.

"K-Katsuki. People are watching," Izuku begged. "This isn't the scene to do this. There's too many Yakuza members here. They will *kill* you."

“They can try,” Katsuki replied callously. His eyes glazed over with vengeance. “Because if everyone in the world thinks I’m a monster, then *fine*.” Katsuki’s mouth curled. “I’ll give them the bloodiest monster they’ve ever seen.”

The next breath he took tasted like gunpowder.

If he was going to burn, then so was this whole goddamn room.

“Hey, you!” One guard yelled out. He grabbed Katsuki by his shoulder and forcefully spun him around. “What do you think you’re doing—”

The guard didn’t have the chance to finish his sentence.

All of Katsuki’s killer reflexes snapped into place at that moment to show his true form. With unnerving speed, Katsuki reached into his blazer, pulled out a loaded gun, and aimed it directly between the guard’s eyes. He pulled the trigger before the next word could even be uttered.

Blood splattered across both Izuku’s and Katsuki’s faces.

Horrified, shrill shrieks erupted all around the room.

Katsuki’s bone chilling gaze sliced towards Izuku. In the reflection of Izuku’s glossy eyes, all Katsuki could see was his mother’s skull with a bullet torn through it. He imagined a burial plot for Izuku and Chisaki, side by side, paying with their lives like his mother paid with her’s.

Immediately, Izuku took the defensive.

He snatched his body backwards as Katsuki whirled his gun on him.

Bullets began to rain down like hail as the crowd began a stampede.

Izuku took off in a sprint, no doubt to go running to his scummy boyfriend. Katsuki was piled on by Yakuza men, but he was stronger. Better. More furious. No one could match his wrath in this moment and no one was going to stop him from exacting his revenge—even if it was the last thing he fucking did.

From there it was carnage—pure, efficient, and *personal*.

Screams erupted all around him as the only thing in his mind was to kill.

He killed because violence was the only language the world had ever taught him, and he would speak it now with perfect fluency. There was no hesitation in his fingers and no remorse in his heart as he cut down person after person, trying to clear a path through to his cowardly husband.

He could barely really recall what he was doing. His movements were being puppeteer by his hurt and his rage, fusing into a two headed beast.

All he knew was to follow the rush of green that was retreating from him and make him pay.

He drowned out that tiny voice of love that was screaming for him to stop.

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki always heard the phrase ‘blacked out in rage’. Many people blacked out when they are utterly consumed by emotions so powerful it was like they turned into a different person.

But what descended on him wasn’t black—it was scarlet.

It poured into his vision like blood flooding beneath a door. Fast, scathing and unstoppable. It drowned out everything else until all he could see was red.

He wanted to drive his blade into Izuku’s throat the same way Izuku had stabbed his heart. Katsuki’s pain tasted like iron in his throat as his inner child cried out from the betrayal. All he wanted was love, but the world decided he wasn’t worthy. So what was the point in pretending like he was anything other than that bloody, scarlet soaked monster everyone saw?

That night, Katsuki gave the world what it wanted.

He painted the ballroom in blood. Body after body dropped as he gunned down every scummy Yakuza in sight. His senses sharpened to a way they had never before, fueled by betrayal and a broken heart.

As he hacked down person after person, he imagined that somewhere his mother was baring her teeth in a grin, happy to be given countless bodies as an offering to her honor. He knew she was a spiteful woman, and he was her son. He was the product of a monster and the most vengeful woman on this planet.

So he became what was in his blood—and showed everyone what he was really made of.

He cut his way through the ball room. The halls. The stairway and into a private room. He decided counting how many lives he claimed was pointless. Because there would never be enough to quell his anger until Izuku and Chisaki were one of those people.

He cut his way up to the roof, cornering Izuku who was running as fast as possible.

They engaged in a tight, close quarter fight that was as fast as the wind. Blow after blow and bullets rained down.

“Katsuki!” Izuku screamed out as he dodged more attempts to gash his neck. “*Wait*!”

Katsuki felt something inside of him slip here, upon hearing Izuku’s cries of pain. His love surged forward, beckoned by Izuku’s voice, trying to overpower his anger. Katsuki’s rage grabbed the very last handgun in his holster and cocked it.

“Katsuki! Please, wait a moment!” Izuku yelled more when Katsuki began to fire off the gun.

Izuku began to go on the defensive. He hid well behind Katsuki, keeping close to his back in order to not give a clear shot. Katsuki tried to whirl around, and failed. He whirled and whirled and the part of him that loved Izuku more than anything was beginning to grow stronger. It was being fed by the sound of Izuku's voice.

"*Please*, Katsuki! We-We can talk—"

"Shut up!" Katsuki viciously yelled. His love for Izuku was growing now, but he quickly capped it. He shoved it down so hard with the simple thought of Izuku kissing Chisaki. "I don't give a fuck what you have to say! After I kill you I'm going to gut your new boyfriend and make you both pay for what you did to my *mother*!"

Katsuki reached behind him and grabbed Izuku's arm. With all his strength, he flung Izuku in front of him and pulled the trigger.

Izuku shrieked as a hot bullet landed in his leg.

His love for Izuku freed itself after hearing that howl of pain. It began to slow him down, and every bullet he tried to land in those dark, gorgeous curls missed. It was as if there was a piece of him that refused to let him finish the job. Katsuki felt his accuracy loosen despite his anger.

He became frustrated with himself, and that slipped into his movements.

He messed up enough that Izuku was able to grab his wrist. Izuku wrangled his arm with both hands. Using both his speed and strength, his backstabbing husband pulled his arm backwards. Izuku did this until Katsuki's shoulder popped out of its socket.

Katsuki screamed, and Izuku screwed his eyes shut.

With blinding speed, Izuku disarmed the gun from Katsuki with the twist of his wrist. Then he hit Katsuki in the side of the head with the blunt end of the weapon twice.

The pain made his vision spot. Ripples of mixed memories flooded Katsuki's head. His mother's laughter melted with Izuku's. Katsuki stumbled. He gasped and grappled for his husband, unsure if he did this out of rage or love.

Then Izuku's beautiful face twisted in a snarl. Tears poured from his eyes as he hauled back.

The final blow landed with a hard crack and Katsuki's world went black.

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki recognized the sensation immediately, he was falling yet again.

It was that same weightless, gut-twisting drop into the deepest recesses of himself. Conscious but not awake. He was trapped in that in-between space where time didn't move and his memories played on loop like film projected across the backs of his eyelids.

When he opened his eyes in the dream, the world was warm.

He was at the park in Yokohama. It was the one with the crooked fountain and that rusted jungle gym kids still climbed like it wasn't falling apart. It was summer, the air was thick with heat and the sky was a bleached blue. Cicadas hummed in the trees, a low, rattling chorus.

His mother stood beside him, squinting against the sun. She had one hand perched on her hip, the other shading her brow.

"Oi. Brat," she said, nudging his arm. "What flavor do you want?"

He blinked. "Mint."

She smirked like she always did, sharp and fond. He found himself grinning back before he could stop it. He paid for the ice cream and they sat down on their usual bench, the one near the dog run. A pair of retrievers barked and tumbled through the grass. It was so stupidly peaceful.

This day had been real. He remembered it clearly, it was the summer after he turned twenty. Just a few months before she was killed.

His mother licked her vanilla ice cream cone once, then turned toward him. Her eyes were softer than he was used to.

"Ah, Katsuki," she started, voice quieter now. "I don't want to be too mushy or anything, but…I really appreciate you—as a son."

He scoffed. "You don't have to go all soft on me."

"I know," she chuckled. "But still. I should say it more often. I know I wasn't the best mom for you, and I have my pitfalls. But I got lucky with you. You turned out...surprisingly okay."

"Oh, so now I'm okay? Not a brat anymore?"

"Don't push it. You're still the biggest knucklehead I've ever met."

He grinned, teeth bared wide and unapologetic. "Wonder where I got it from."

She laughed, elbowing him in the ribs. For a moment, the pain between them peeled away. He felt like a normal kid somehow. There was no blood on his hands. No ghosts in his chest. He was just a boy with his mother on a blistering summer day, and their ice cream was melting too fast to finish.

And then she hugged him.

The familiar scent of her faint perfume and sunscreen mixed. He shifted, too awkward, but then returned the hug slowly. Some of her ice cream smeared against his cheek, and they both burst out laughing.

She wiped it away with her thumb, eyes crinkling in the sunlight. She gazed at him proudly, happy to be his mother.

“Hey,” she said after a beat. “Let’s take a trip for New Year’s. Some mother and son time! We haven’t done a trip by ourselves and I have to admit I am jealous of how much you travel with Aizawa.”

Katsuki tilted his head. “Where should we go?”

She shrugged, took a bite of her ice cream, and leaned back like the weight of the world wasn’t hanging over either of them. “Anywhere. Wherever you want to go, brat.”

The answer came easy. “You always said you wanted to go to Paris.”

Her face lit up like he’d handed her the damn world—and that’s all he ever wanted, really.

“Oh my god, yes!” she gasped. “Let’s do that!”

He began to imagine their trip and his heart soared happily. His mother had been doing so much better these last two years. She was on medication. She didn’t gamble. And she kept a stable job now. She even made sure to eat healthily and their relationship had improved dramatically. They had finally arrived at a point where he officially got the mother he always hoped for.

Then the memory started to fade around the edges. The color bled out like ink in water, drifting away in swirls. Then the cicadas softened and the heat thinned.

Because while it was a nice memory, that’s all it was.

They never got to take that trip, because their future was robbed of them.

☽ ☽ ☽

Morning after the Scarlet Masquerade

Katsuki didn’t know how long he’d been unconscious. He only knew that the sky outside the narrow slats had shifted and woke him up. His head throbbed in slow, punishing waves. Each pulse was a brutal echo behind his eyes. It felt like something inside his skull had cracked—and maybe it had.

He groaned and dragged one hand across the cramped metal. His legs were twisted beneath him, nearly numb from the unnatural position. And his spine screamed when he shifted.

Early winter winds blew in and bit his skin.

When he finally forced his eyes open, squinting against the sickly light, he pulled his senses together. He was stuffed in a ventilation shaft. He nearly laughed at the irony. He was shoved in here like trash.

His chest was hurting, but he moved anyway. His arms shook as he braced against the sides. His knees collapsed under him. He bit back a curse and gritted his teeth.

Then he craned his neck, peering through the grate.

Across the roof, it was entirely empty. No Yakuza were around, which meant that the coast was clear for now. He knew he needed to hurry and take the opening. He shoved at the cover, and it gave with a hollow clatter.

He climbed out, and dropped down hard, fully landing on his side. Without warning, a lightning bolt of pain cut across his skull.

He grabbed the spot where Izuku had struck him hard. Pain spotted across his vision as he recalled the way those cutthroat green eyes tore into him moments before the final blow.

Then, his anger returned. All from the single thought about Izuku. The whole night's events flashed before his eyes. Izuku smiling at Chisaki. Holding his hand. Dancing with him. *Kissing* him.

But worst of all—Izuku knew for the entire last month that he killed his mother. Izuku had sat there, at her grave, and told Katsuki to his face that he loved him. All while knowing the reason she was dead was *his* fault. And then he had left to find comfort in the arms of the man who paid him to kill her.

The fire in Katsuki reignited as he thought about that one summer day with his mother.

His anger wasn't as uncontrollable this time. But it was sturdy, rooted well in vengeful resolve. He was going to make sure those who killed his mother paid the blood toll. His hurt sat on top of his love for Izuku, pushing the shards of his broken heart far beneath the surface.

Tears cut down his face in a combination of grief, sadness and betrayal. He clenched his jaw and wiped away the pitiful wetness along his cheek that mixed with the dried blood.

The pain inside of him was too much.

He needed to get it out before it tore him apart.

Aizawa had always said revenge wouldn't fix anything. The old man claimed vengeance was a poison people swallowed hoping someone else would die. That all that type of hatred left behind was scorched earth and hollow men.

But Katsuki didn't care. Because right now, with a broken heart eating him alive, he was certain of only one thing: the one way to heal the pain inside of him—the only way to *kill* the thing tearing him apart from within—was to get his hands on Chisaki and Izuku and bury them both for what they took from him.

Then maybe, after all these years, he could finally stop hurting.

☽ ☽ ☽

When he left, there were cops and Yakuza buzzing around. He had to use extra sleuth and be extremely mindful when scaling down the venue. It was a miracle no one had searched the vent he was shoved into, and he had to wonder who put him in there.

The side of him that loved Izuku told him the answer: Izuku himself.

But he was too hurt to dwell on it.

He got his bike and bags and made his way to a seedy motel. It was small and far away from the scene of the crime. He looked over his shoulder all the while, feeling as if a set of eyes were crawling on him.

When he made his way into his room, the first thing that greeted him was a long, full length mirror that was cracked directly above where Katsuki's heart was. The reflection showed a distorted version of himself he had never seen before. He walked up to it, dropping his bag and helmet on the floor.

He was covered in blood, head to toe.

It was smeared on his skin, caked in places that he didn't know were possible. He looked at his hands at that moment, and all he could see was red. He waited for the voices of self deprecation to come with their hurtful words—but they didn't.

For the first time in Katsuki's life, he wasn't even the slightest bit ashamed of what he was.

He was happy to be that monster everyone feared. He finally accepted his birth rite as the bastard son of Imasuji Goto. His biological father was a true horrible, vicious human being—and now, Katsuki was his successor.

He breathed out shakily, understanding himself fully for once for what he was. That darkness inside of him wasn't another entity. It was just him. He was the bloodthirsty one. He was the one who craved violence and justified it.

The new sense of self rotated in his chest like a blade and came out the other side sharp with rage.

He looked down at the ring on his finger and felt that anger boil again. Slowly, Katsuki removed it from his hand. It was painful to accept that a future with Izuku was no longer real but even more painful to accept he had been fooled for so long.

Bitterly, he threw the ring on top of his bag.

He turned then, ripping his eyes away from his cracked reflection. He began to strip down and head into the shower. He knew he needed to get a move on within the next hour, maximum. He had been sloppy at the masquerade. Had he'd plan to kill that many Yakuza, he would've been better prepared. But he didn't anticipate lighting up the whole room like that in a fit of heartbreak and jealousy.

But Katsuki knew what he had to do after this.

He was going to kill Bakugou Izuku and Chisaki Kai.

And he was starting with his deceitful husband.

☽ ☽ ☽

When he finished showering, Katsuki gave himself stitches. He mended the multiple cuts and gunshot wounds he sustained. He ate the pain like it was nothing as he dressed and cleaned all the gashes in his body using his first aid kit.

In the background, he played the small TV the motel had to offer. The news was running, and it was detailing the horrific night that had fallen upon Tokyo.

The Scarlet Masquerade is what they were calling it.

Over forty people were murdered, and quite possibly more. Many of the news channels suspected it to be gang activity, but never outright named the Yakuza. Likely because of the Chisaki family's death grip on politicians in Japan. And lucky for him, his name wasn't dropped. Which meant he was in the clear for the time being.

However, as he listened to the TV, another story caught his eye.

On the screen now were The Viper Academy skyscrapers. The once polished silver buildings were singed black at the bottom. Where the parking garage used to be was now absolutely nothing. It looked like true scorched earth, empty and burned down to the foundation.

Katsuki furrowed his brow as he knotted the last stitch in his arm.

"What the hell?" He whispered.

But before his thoughts could marinate, a loud sequence of knocks hit his door.

Katsuki turned his head and tightly clenched his jaw. His eyes were sharp, restricted down and ready to collect another soul.

When he didn't answer, the knock came again.

"I know you're in there, Bakugou Katsuki," a deep, smooth voice of a man announced. "I followed you here from the masquerade venue. You slipped past the cops well but I saw you leave through the alley."

Katsuki immediately stood up and got his handgun. He cocked it with a loud, threatening clank and turned the barrel towards the door.

"No need for that." The voice said. "I come in peace and I'm not law enforcement."

Katsuki scoffed. "You have until the count of ten to get the fuck out of here before I pump that door with lead."

"Like I said, that won't be necessary," the man repeated, a bit more testily. "I'm here to propose an idea that might be of interest to you. I don't mean any harm. I promise, I am unarmed."

Katsuki scowled. He walked up to the door on edge, gun still raised. He looked through the peephole. In the distorted fishbowl lens he saw a man with dark crimson eyes and stark white hair pulled back in a bun. Katsuki's frown deepened when he caught the viper tattoos on the man's neck and hands.

Slowly, he opened the door just enough to crack it open, making the chain lock stretch taut.

Two pairs of sharp red eyes met through the narrow gap.

Katsuki paused and assessed.

The man in front of him was covered neck down in viper tattoos. On either set of his knuckles were the words 'VIPER' and 'SNAKE' in bold ink and he was dressed in expensive looking all black garments. His face had a large, giant gash over one eye and there were cracks embedded in his skin.

Katsuki recognized this guy.

This was the same man that got out of the limo with Chisaki and Izuku at the masquerade. And now that he was closer, Katsuki knew why he seemed so familiar earlier. He had seen this man briefly, right before he and Izuku left for Biei. It was when he had been at the cafe waiting for Izuku to go grab his bag.

This was the guy who let his dogs mangle someone who simply bumped into him.

Katsuki heightened his guard.

"Hello. My name is Shigaraki," the man said smoothly. His void-like eyes bored into him and sent chills right down Katsuki's spine. He bowed, ever so slightly. "I'm Izuku's handler."

Katsuki frowned. He followed his gut and clutched his gun tighter.

"Handler?" He asked, entirely unfriendly. "So you're the leader of that Viper Academy?"

"Something like that," Shigaraki said. "I was raised there as an agent, and I am now second in command."

"And why are you here at my motel room?" Katsuki hissed.

Shigaraki didn't blink. His eyes gazed at Katsuki, giving nothing.

"I would like to hire you for an assignment," he said. "I think you're the only one who could do it and our interests align at the moment. It would be beneficial for us to work together."

Katsuki leered and reeled back. "You're kidding, right?"

"No. I'm not." Shigaraki put his hands in his pockets and tilted his head. "I have a…*situation* on my hands that I can't handle myself right now. Izuku has fled Tokyo and he left a lot of chaos behind him. And unfortunately, I can't go after him since I have to clean up the mess he left behind after upsetting the Shie Hassaikai."

The fire on the news burned to the front of Katsuki's mind.

"Why me?" Katsuki asked. "Just get some of your other agents to go get him."

"Not possible," Shigaraki replied. He tightened his jaw and exhaled exhaustively. "I can't exactly count on simply anyone to bring in Izuku with his level of lethality. He would easily cut down whoever I sent his way. You, however, would be able to bring him back with less resistance because of your…"

Shigaraki paused, looked Katsuki up and down, and frowned distastefully.

"…relationship," he finished.

Katsuki didn't like the way the last word was said. It was spat with so much resentment and disapproval it stung his skin. He decided then to show his gun, fully letting this Shigaraki know he wasn't fucking around with him.

"And how exactly do you know Izuku and I are involved?" Katsuki questioned defensively. He leaned against the doorway, gun in hand and finger on the trigger.

Shigaraki narrowed his eyes. "I make it my business to know everything, and *everyone*, Izuku does."

"Is that so?" Katsuki chuckled humorlessly, immediately thinking of Chisaki. "Sorry. I don't trust fucking snakes anymore. You'll have to hire someone else."

He made a move to close the door, but quickly, the man shot his arm out and held it open. Katsuki sneered threateningly but Shigaraki remained calm. He pushed the door back open, the latch chain rattling.

"I promise I can make it worth your while," Shigaraki said persuasively. "If you bring Izuku to me, I can give you something that you can't achieve on your own."

"There's not a damn thing you can give me—"

"—I can offer you Chisaki."

Katsuki halted.

He hesitantly looked at Shigaraki sideways.

"See? I told you I could make it worth your while," Shigaraki mused when he realized he caught Katsuki's attention. "I can give you the perfect opening to kill Chisaki with your bare hands. Even a cherry on top to torture him like I know the infamous Scarlet Eyed Killer likes to do."

At the mention of his alias, Katsuki understood this man knew more about him than he led on. Playing his cards carefully, he toned down his abrasiveness. But he couldn't help but grow curious at the thought of getting an opening at killing Chisaki.

"…How exactly would you make that possible?" Katsuki questioned.

"I work close enough with him to the point he foolishly trusts me. It would be easy for me to set him up."

"And why would you be okay with that if you work together?"

"Because I am going to kill Chisaki eventually," Shigaraki admitted. He shrugged like murdering the Yakuza Heir was a small task. "It doesn't matter to me if I kill him or not; I just need him gone and out of the way after some power transfer happens. However, it matters to you—correct? You want to be the one who makes him feel that pain. And I can make that happen."

Katsuki sucked at his teeth. He toyed with the idea as he thought about ways to murder Chisaki.

Getting an opening to kill Chisaki wasn't going to be an easy task. The Yakuza Heir had endless bodyguards, territories and politicians he could hide behind. It would be like going up against an army in order to even get a chance to slit that man's throat.

"All you have to do is bring me Izuku," Shigaraki emphasized smoothly.

Katsuki narrowed his eyes at the snake in front of him. "And what would you do with him?"

"I would simply bring him back to his comfortable life. Nothing more, nothing less."

Katsuki's mouth pulled down further in a frown. "You're going to have to give me more than that."

"Izuku is my most valuable asset," Shigaraki explained evenly. "Right now, the longer he is on the run, the more the Shie Hassaikai will hunt him. If I get to him first, I can make sure he is protected from their fury and bring him back under my wing. After all this blows over, he will continue to be treated well: clothed in the finest name brands and fed the highest quality food like he always has been. We don't treat our agents poorly, I'm sure you know this."

He did.

Izuku had a far more comfortable life than he ever would have guessed.

"Look at where he lives," Shigaraki pushed, leaning closer. His voice spun like a spell, hooking Katsuki in. "Look at the *clothing* he has. He's been living a life of luxury with a silver spoon since he can remember. I have no intention of harming him. My only honest goal in life is that I want what's best for Izuku. If you give him to me, he'll be safe and Chisaki will be yours."

Katsuki could imagine it.

Izuku would be back at home in that oceanside mansion of his. He would be reading his books, swimming in his pool and playing with Katsuma probably until the end of his days.

For some reason, from the outside looking in, Katsuki didn't think Izuku's life seemed so bad.

Maybe that's why Izuku didn't seem petrified to return—or maybe that's why he stayed all these years.

But still.

When Katsuki remembered the way Izuku had broken down at the sight of a belt—he wasn't sure what was the real mirage. He didn't doubt Izuku was abused. But really, none of that mattered anymore. What really mattered was getting his revenge on the two lovers who broke his world in two.

He pushed aside his feelings for Izuku and tightened his jaw.

"No deal," Katsuki sneered. "Sorry, but I want them both dead."

"Think of the bigger picture here," Shigaraki suggested. "Why blame Izuku more than the Yakuza Heir?"

"Why choose?" Katsuki flicked his wrist, dismissing the whole idea. "I'm passing up on your offer. You're going to lose your biggest asset unless you kill me right here and now."

A dark flicker swarmed around Shigaraki's eyes. An uncomfortable wave tore through Katsuki the longer the man looked at him. It wasn't murderous intent, but rather something darker and rooted in true loathing.

Tediously, Shigaraki removed his hand from the door. He took a relaxed posture and tilted his chin upwards.

"I'll give you time to think about it," Shigaraki said snidely.

He was calm, like he knew this was going to happen. From his deep pockets, he pulled out a little navy-blue flip phone and a small piece of paper with some writing on it.

He handed it to Katsuki through the door without any sort of hesitation.

"When you change your mind, my contact is on this phone," Shigaraki said. "Press the dial and I'll answer. Also, here is a lead on Izuku. He set fire to the garage at home and slowed us down. But after we got the flames under control, I noticed one car was unaccounted for."

Katsuki hesitantly took the phone and paper.

Something about this screamed trap. But when he glanced it all over, it was legit. He flipped open the phone and there was a single contact inside: '117'. And on the piece of paper written in red ink was the make, model, color and license plate of a car.

Katsuki's frown deepened. This felt a little too easy and didn't add up.

"Why are you giving me this if you need him alive?" Katsuki asked, on edge.

“Think of it as a thank you for putting the Yakuza in disarray for me,” Shigaraki answered without any bite. He took a step back and smiled at Katsuki in a knowing way. “You gave me just enough of an opening to get my foot solidly in the door.”

Shigaraki began to walk away, not even properly saying goodbye. He turned down the hallway and from here, Katsuki could see a number in ink on the nape of his neck. 117.

Shigaraki lifted up his hand to wave back to him as he walked away.

“Enjoy your road to revenge, Bakugou Katsuki.”

☽ ☽ ☽

The first thing Katsuki did was hook the phone Shigaraki gifted him up to his laptop. He used his advanced tech application he designed when he was eighteen. He scanned the tiny device for tracking software or anything that could be used against him.

Unsurprisingly, he found the phone was tapped.

A dry, bitter laugh cracked from his throat. Katsuki leaned back in the chair, lips twitching at the pathetic attempt. This guy thought he was stupid.

With a few keystrokes, he traced the malware, dismantled the transmitter, and wiped the trace logs. The phone’s insides were totally clean now, leaving no issue of him being traced. But he was still offended that Shigaraki underestimated him that much.

Goddamn snakes.

Katsuki’s hand hovered over the trash bin with the phone. He was about to throw the whole thing away—

—but stopped.

His rage echoed in his belly and prevented him from tossing the phone in the trash.

He sucked at his teeth. Without thinking too hard, Katsuki decided to keep it. He placed it in his cargo pants right next to his own, black colored smartphone.

Next, Katsuki moved to searching CCTV footage on his laptop.

He pulled up his custom application, the one he’d built at twenty. It was an automated crawler that combed surveillance networks by radius. Plug in coordinates, enter a license plate or description, and the thing scrapes everything within that custom set radius. His laptop hummed loudly as it ran the code and spat back out the results.

Lucky for him, a candy pink Ferrari Purosangue wasn’t exactly subtle.

The hits came in under ten minutes, popping up as little green dots showing Izuku’s trail.

It looked like Izuku was heading south—and rather fast. All the snapshots showed him running various stop lights or speeding fast enough to be given a ticket.

Katsuki's eyes scanned all the photos until he landed on the final one, showing where Izuku was last spotted. It was grainy, low-res, but clear enough. A still frame locked on the driver's side. It was Izuku behind the wheel, caught in the middle of an illegal left turn in Osaka.

He zoomed in on his husband's lethal green eyes.

Katsuki leaned back, lips parting in a gesture that wasn't quite a smile. He twirled the flimsy scrap of paper Shigaraki had given him between two fingers, like a match he was about to strike.

"Gotcha, darling," he sneered.

Chapter End Notes

Thanks so much for reading and coming along with the journey!! I appreciate you all so much. Let me know what you think below <3 I love everyone's theories and comments! I hope you have a great day!

Chapter 39: Morendo

Chapter Summary

> Morendo (Stylistic indication) To play in a way that gradually grow softer and then dies away.

Chapter Notes

> Hello everyone!!! :)) The power of angst is really motivating me to write (plus all the good weather since it's summer where I live now. I had a really good hiking session and took up bouldering this week so my endorphins are kinda high)
>
> We're barreling right down this story!! I hope you enjoy <3 Big thank you like always to the LOML Luna for betaing <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 39 — Morendo

.

.

.

Katsuki could admit he liked a good chase.

There was a rhythm to it that he thrived on. The pressure building under his skin. The slim chances of his prey escaping. The look of terror when his victim realized there was no way out.

It was a perfect hit of exhilarating thrill right before he killed someone.

And he couldn’t deny Izuku running from him always did ignite heat in his veins.

His husband was the only one who’d ever escaped him and lived to tell the tale—an anomaly of green in a world Katsuki painted red. But he knew that this hunt would be the sweetest yet. Because after all this time, he was going to track Izuku down and kill him exactly like he should’ve done years ago.

He harnessed his hatred and drove furiously all the way down to Osaka.

When he arrived, he checked his black smartphone for any more hits on the pink Ferrari. He found none. Either Izuku ditched the car or, more realistically, he was resting up somewhere.

Katsuki knew Izuku well enough to know he was definitely resting—but not for long.

It only took thirty minutes to find where Izuku stashed the car.

He scoped out the radius of the last hit and decided to think like a damn nerd. And that brought him to a small, parking garage in the heart of Osaka, Minami district. He was sure that pint sized Deku thought the flashy car would blend in like camouflage into the neon cladded area.

Izuku hid the vehicle on the third floor in a corner.

As he approached, Katsuki thought it might've been abandoned. But when he looked inside, he saw a sleek, beautiful katana sitting in the passenger seat.

A sadistic grin stretched across Katsuki's face, like a cat who caught a little mouse.

He knew damn well Izuku would come back for that thing. The other assassin wouldn't *dream* of leaving such a perfectly good weapon behind. He was far too thorough.

Katsuki then fished out a small black tracking device from his pocket. It was no bigger than his pinky nail and entirely undetectable to any sniffers. He bent down low and placed it under the belly of the car. He shifted a bit, trying to find the right curve to shove it into.

Then boom, it clicked into place. A smirk bloomed across his face.

Then suddenly, he heard the smallest shuffle—and it sounded exactly like goddamn Deku.

He'd come to know the way Izuku moved over the years. There'd been many, irritating moments when the other assassin tried to sneak past him, attempting to kill a mark Katsuki was protecting. Several times he'd succeeded. But after so many endless run ins, Katsuki perfectly honed his ears for those quiet, little footsteps so that Izuku could never catch him off guard.

He straightened his spine and sharply scanned the garage.

His eyes landed on a pillar not too far from the car. It looked about Deku sized.

Katsuki tilted his chin down and snapped in place all his stealthiness.

He moved, entirely soundless.

He remained light on his feet in a way Aizawa drilled into him. His ex-supervisor always reprimanded Katsuki for his heavy footsteps. The old man said he held too much presence when entering a room. He said that Katsuki needed to learn how to turn it off if he ever was going to be a proper hitman.

So, Katsuki spent years practicing sneaking up on people. He did this until he was totally undetectable to a mark. He now could sink his knife in someone's throat without them ever hearing him coming.

His hunter side kicked in as he moved away from the car.

He kept his eye on the pillar and carefully peered around it. He saw Izuku doing the same on the opposite side, trying to see if he was still near the car.

Katsuki snuck up on him. He drew close then squatted down slowly directly beside Izuku, a mere three inches away.

His oblivious husband peered around the pillar more, clearly confused as to where he'd gone. Then he stiffened his body to stay as quiet as possible. Katsuki had to hold back a laugh.

It was cute how Izuku thought he could hide from him.

Katsuki tilted his head and waited for him to notice.

Izuku seemed to become more confused. Katsuki watched, fully amused as the beautiful man shifted to look the other direction around the pillar.

And when he turned his head, their eyes locked.

They were close enough to kiss, Katsuki thought distantly. But he was also close enough to kill, he thought more ferociously.

"This is the part where you run from me," Katsuki whispered, breath gliding across Izuku's lips.

Izuku took off and instantly Katsuki shot his hands out to seize both his wrists. Izuku tried to snatch himself out of the hold with all his might. But Katsuki's grasp was painfully firm. Katsuki leered as Izuku began to struggle fiercely—he wasn't going to let Izuku out of his sights again.

This would be the final goddamn chase they ever had.

And chase they did.

Izuku annoyingly, but not unexpectedly, tore himself out of Katsuki's grip. Katsuki rebounded easily as Izuku bolted through the parking garage.

His husband zoomed through the concrete structure in a desperate, almost beautiful way trying to escape. But it was foolish. Much like when a bird slammed itself against glass, desperate for the sky and freedom on the other side.

Because like always, Katsuki was right on his heels.

Katsuki's footsteps thundered behind Izuku's lightning speed. The crackle and boom of their electricity surged through the air. It filled the atmosphere with clean, terrifying energy as

Katsuki dug right into his newfound killer instincts.

Katsuki's anger was thicker. His eyes were sharper. His agony homed in all his senses.

But most of all, Katsuki embraced his monstrous identity. His new sense of self gave him a savage brutality he never knew he possessed. Maybe it was genetic, gifted by Imasuji Goto.

In a sharp flash, he wondered if this was why Aizawa always discouraged him from enjoying killing. Aizawa probably knew that if Katsuki got the chance to embrace his bloodlust, he would be transformed into a real, wicked monster.

He remained hot on Izuku's tail. Matched every pivot. Every sprint. Every reckless dodge Izuku took—Katsuki kept up.

But he also recognized their strengths.

Izuku was faster—always had been. Izuku could find a way to break free and fly away from him with speed Katsuki didn't possess. But Katsuki was stronger. The second the distance closed, he could overpower Izuku and drag him right back into his arms. So they continued like this. With Katsuki gaining the advantage. Then Izuku. Then Katsuki again and Izuku once more.

Their endless dance landed them in the Osaka night market, tearing through the mass of people like a tornado.

Screams wrapped around them as they engaged in a close, tight chase. The crowd split open like flesh under pressure. Mothers scooped up their children. Merchants grabbed their wares. Paper lanterns strung above rattled in the sudden, unnatural gust of wind stirred up by their clashing storm.

Izuku ducked through the dense crowd, nimble and fast. He extended his arm in a hurry and grabbed a parasol from a merchant in passing. Then he turned around and swung.

They engaged blow for blow with Katsuki's knife and Izuku's newly found parasol.

For every jab Izuku was able to land, Katsuki blocked two more. He was quicker than he was at the masquerade because the determination in his heart was stronger. Katsuki started matching Izuku's skilled footing.

Izuku began to stagger as Katsuki started to gain on him. With every attack, he slashed away at the flimsy parasol, wearing it down. Right as the parasol seemed like it was about to break, Izuku cursed under his breath.

He tried to turn and run.

But Katsuki grabbed his duffle bag in an unforgiving hold.

Izuku yelped as he was brutally yanked backwards. He nearly fell, but balanced on his heels. He tried to grab his bag back, but Katsuki was always stronger. Izuku used all his agility to

whirl and strike. Katsuki gritted his teeth as Izuku began to beat him with the parasol like he was some goddamn piñata.

While Izuku did this, Katsuki reached into his cargo pants' pocket. He pulled out a tracker.

He had a feeling that Izuku might get away. Because somehow, Izuku always did.

So he placed a safety measurement right on the back of Deku's duffle bag. It snapped into place with its tiny teeth right in time. Izuku broke away from him and in movements too fast to recall, trapped his arm in the parasol, closed it, and with a giant yell of effort and impressive strength, whirled him into one of the merchant stands.

It was a wash after that. He tried to keep up with Izuku, but the man retreated faster than the wind. Izuku sprinted for the docks, barreling towards a departing boat.

Katsuki was right behind him, gun drawn—and he was aiming to kill.

His sights lined up with Izuku's skull. His finger curled tight against the trigger. One pull. That was all it would take. One bullet to cauterize the wound inside of him that never stopped bleeding.

Right when he had a clear shot—his hand shook. The bullet veered.

He tried again, but the same thing happened. He clenched his teeth and attempted to tighten his aim.

But his hands began to tremble out of control.

Izuku leapt for the departing boat, grabbing onto one of the ropes. He dangled there, completely vulnerable.

Katsuki took aim for Izuku's head again—

—and right as he pulled the trigger, his heart intensely spasmed.

He flinched, in shock and in pain, and the bullet landed in Izuku's arm instead of his skull.

Katsuki skidded to a halt at the end of the pier. He clutched at his heart, stunned.

He had the shot. What happened? Why the *hell* did that happen?

His eyes were wild as he assessed what was going on—and what he found was infuriating. Standing directly in front of his new found killer instincts was his love for Izuku. He thought he left it at the masquerade ball, but it followed him, festering inside.

Katsuki looked up. He watched, seething, as the boat took off.

After a moment, Katsuki could see Izuku peak from over the ledge of the boat. Those stunning green eyes landed on him, cutting through the dark night. Katsuki calmly stared

back, heart fluttering despite himself. Even in the dead of night, Izuku's eyes were radiant. They pulled him in and slowly, all his anger melted away under that beautiful gaze.

Loud police sirens began to make their way to the night market.

Katsuki pulled his hood over his head. He didn't break eye contact with Izuku, spun under the spell of those alluring eyes. It wasn't until he turned away did he finally pull himself back.

He walked away quickly from the scene, and disappeared into the mayhem of the night.

Hundreds of people were tightly packed together, gasping and pointing in all different directions. As the blue and red lights approached, Katsuki pushed himself deep into an alley. The police ran right past the crooked passageway he was tucked into. They endlessly searched in the thick crowd of people who were all giving conflicting, confusing recollections.

As he walked back to his motorcycle, Katsuki pulled out his phone. He clicked open his tracker app and saw the tiny, blinking green dot on the map.

It was slowly moving across the Osaka Bay.

"See you soon, Deku," Katsuki hissed.

☽ ☽ ☽

The green dot on his phone crept across the water and stalled on Awaji Island. It blinked steadily on the island's edge like a heartbeat waiting to stop.

Katsuki followed it closely, driving past the speed limit along the edge of Osaka Bay.

Along the way, Katsuki's thoughts snagged on what occured at the docks. He couldn't move past the fact his hand shook like that. What bad fucking timing.

Katsuki mulled over this, unhappily. He reviewed the last eight years in his head—and something he didn't notice before stood out: every time he aimed his gun at Izuku, his hands were shaky. Anyone else, his hands were still and precise.

He thought this was because of his pure, unchecked rage for the man. It made sense that he trembled when holding the gun whenever it came to that goddamn Deku because of how much he hated him. But now, he wasn't sure hatred was the cause.

A tiny, quiet whisper in the back of his head told him the answer.

But he didn't want to listen to it.

By the time he arrived on Awaji Island, the wind turned cold and sharp. It sliced through his jacket like it possessed teeth. The chill heightened his excitement, because while the wind howled, so did Katsuki's inner beast. The adrenaline in his veins was pulsating being so close to his prey.

He followed Izuku's tracker all the way to a forgotten stretch of cracked road. There, a shitty roadside motel sat against the night sky. The blue neon sign sputtered on and off, barely clinging on. There were no cars in the lot and no signs of life.

Katsuki parked his bike right out front, boots hitting the pavement with finality. As he kicked down the stand, satisfaction began to coil tight in his gut like a loaded gun.

On his phone screen, the distance between the green dot and his own glowing orange one was closing.

Katsuki walked into the motel with his jaw set. The bell chimed above him like a warning siren announcing his entrance. The first thing that greeted him was the smell of old dust and residual nicotine. The faded floral wallpaper stood out a bit in contrast with the bleakness of the motel.

Which Katsuki all thought was fine for the crime scene it was about to become.

He walked straight up to the man sitting at the check-in. He noted the employee had an oily comb over and large, round glasses.

Of course, the clerk didn't see him at first. His eyes were plastered to his laptop, clearly watching porn.

Katsuki tried his best to not focus on the lewd image that was reflected through the crooked glasses of the man. But when the employee didn't even notice he was standing there, Katsuki unhappily slammed his hand on the bell.

The man jumped and yelped. Immediately, his eyes went wide. He snatched his headphones from his ears and slammed his laptop shut. He gawked at Katsuki, entirely surprised to see someone actually wanting service at this shit hole.

"Watching porn on the job?" Katsuki sneered, unfriendly. "I should call management and report you."

"No! Please don't!" The man instantly begged. He straightened out and clasped his hands together. "We don't get customers this time of night, I swear! Please, this is my fifth strike, I'll lose the job if you report it."

"Oh, really?" Katsuki grinned fiendishly as he leaned across the counter. "I'll tell you what, I won't report this on two conditions."

The man nodded frantically. "Ye-Yes of course, *anything*!"

"First, you tell me which room he went to," Katsuki said as he lifted up his phone screen, showing Izuku's picture. "And the second, you take this 60,000 yen right here and not report anything you see or hear for the next twenty four hours."

He pulled a wad of crisp bills from his coat and dropped it on the counter.

The man froze, taken back. He assessed Katsuki cautiously. His eyes flickered between the phone and then the cash.

Katsuki raised a perfectly plucked brow and waited. He knew this man would cave. Men like him always did.

And just like he predicted, the man took the money.

“He’s in room 201,” the clerk whispered.

Katsuki grinned with all his teeth. He leaned back and turned toward the hallway.

“Enjoy the rest of your video,” he called, voice dry and humorless.

☽ ☽ ☽

Killer red eyes tightened as he watched the distance between the two dots on the map grow smaller and smaller.

He walked along the ledge of the outdoor hallway, looking closely at the green dot on his phone. He passed by dark window after dark window of the hotel rooms. Then when he rounded the corner, he saw a single, golden light spilling out from one room.

Katsuki looked down at his phone. The distance in kilometers was nearly zero. His heart began to race again. His stomach tightened at the thought of getting close to his prey.

As he walked forward, suddenly the blinking green light disappeared—a sign that Izuku must’ve discovered the tracker and destroyed it. Then the light in front of him was killed in an instant.

Katsuki scoffed, unable to stop the mean sneer that spread across his lips.

“A little too late for that,” he muttered, voice low and cruel.

He slipped the phone into his pocket and pulled out his lock pick without breaking stride. Passing the dark window, he paused at the door. His heart thumped loudly as he began to easily unlock it.

The lock popped and he stepped inside with the gentleness of a demon.

His restricted eyes scanned the dark space.

The motel room was exactly what he expected. A single bed with a TV, dresser, closet and bathroom tucked away in the corner. But none of that mattered. What mattered was that Katsuki could feel the fear in the air.

It was tangible, like static electricity silently humming beneath the silence.

He breathed it in slowly. His eyes adjusted to the dark as his hands clenched in excitement.

He closed the door behind him and locked it tight.

He moved like a shadow, shifting his weight to soundless. He searched carefully for that beautiful man he's been chasing all his life.

He passed the bed and checked the closet first. When that was empty he looked behind the dresser and under the desk. He pivoted carefully on his heels towards the bathroom, wondering if there was a window Izuku crawled out of—but there was none. And Izuku wasn't there.

Which left one more option.

He walked back to the bedroom and cut his eyes down to the ground.

He slowly crouched and there he was. His small Izuku, trying to crawl away.

Katsuki grinned cruelly with all his teeth.

Clever, darling. But not clever enough.

Katsuki's hands shot out, grasping Izuku's ankles. His hands wrapped all the way around and he pulled. He drank in the sound of Izuku's terrified, surprised yelp as he tugged him backwards with all his might.

Izuku tried to struggle against him, but it was useless. He was always stronger.

But that damn Izuku was always quicker. He twisted immediately when he was pulled from underneath the bed. Then he aimed his gun directly at Katsuki's arm. Katsuki tried to dodge, but Izuku's trigger finger was lethal as lightning.

Katsuki yelled as he was shot point blank range. Pain seared across his whole arm. He went flying back into the wall with the force as the bullet ripped clean through his bicep.

He drowned down the pain with all his vengeful thoughts. Make Izuku pay for killing his mother. That's all that mattered. Not the agony. Not the burning voice in his head that was screaming at him to stop—but simply his mother.

Him and Izuku fought again. But this time it was different.

There was a surge of finality in the air.

Izuku came at him fast, swinging the butt of his gun toward Katsuki's temple. But Katsuki saw it coming. He caught Izuku's wrist mid-swing and twisted it until Izuku screamed. The gun clattered to the floor.

Izuku moved quickly, launching his legs up around Katsuki's neck and choking him with brutal precision. Katsuki pried at Izuku's thighs, fingers digging in. But Izuku held tight and began to suffocate him. Katsuki stood, lifting him like dead weight. He began blindly slamming them against anything he could find. The walls. The dresser. The bed frame.

The room trembled under their vicious collision, breaking and bending to their will.

Izuku tightened his hold, grabbed Katsuki's hair, and drove his elbow down again and again. Katsuki's vision blinked white. He hissed, realizing Izuku was attempting to knock him out again.

He then blindly hurled them both into the mirror.

Glass exploded around them. Shards sharply flung in the air and cut them both.

Izuku faltered. That was all Katsuki needed.

He ripped Izuku off and slammed him down. They grappled, hands slipping on blood and sweat. Izuku struck first with a wild kick—catching Katsuki in the jaw. The impact knocked him sideways. But he caught Izuku again before he could run and tackled him into the nightstand.

An elbow hit his throat. A lamp broke over his back. Katsuki staggered. Izuku ran. Katsuki dragged him down by the leg, pinned him.

They fought like animals. Grappling. Scratching. Punching and kicking.

Memories of his mother rushed forward, driving him on.

With every hit he saw her stiff body. With every punch he heard himself crying there in her living room for hours. His eyes began to burn as he thought about Izuku poisoning him. Leaving him alone to find that red folder. All while Izuku went back to his real lover, Chisaki. Not giving a single damn about him.

Izuku grabbed the sheets, wrapped them around Katsuki's head, and wrenched free. But Katsuki's blade hissed through the linen, cutting through.

Izuku sprinted for the door. Katsuki pinned him down by stabbing through his pant leg. The thud of Izuku's skull against the floor was deafening. Izuku clawed for the doorknob. Katsuki dragged him back in one fell swoop.

Katsuki pinned Izuku down. He forced himself between Izuku's legs, pressing every ounce of his weight down. Then his hands found Izuku's delicate throat—and squeezed.

Izuku thrashed. He scratched at Katsuki's hands and kicked but it was useless. Katsuki was always stronger. He pushed his weight down and overpowered Izuku fully.

Katsuki held on as Izuku gasped. There was no love in the hold this time. Only muscle, memory, and the inevitability of the tragedy they'd become.

Izuku looked up at him. He was terrified.

Katsuki stared. And for a moment, time fractured.

Suddenly, beneath him wasn't the Izuku he'd been hunting but rather the Izuku he'd only wanted to protect. He saw that version of Izuku, in Biei, basked in warm, honey light that spilled in from the window. He was at the kitchen table, stirring sugar in his tea with a spoon. That saccharine version of Izuku smiled and gestured for him to come closer.

Katsuki blinked, hard.

He willed away the memory and continued his stead-fast resolve.

But then, he saw Izuku give up the fight. Izuku's hands went slack at his sides, but his eyes stayed gazing up at Katsuki. In those beautiful viridian irises was nothing but love and resignation. The two mixed together in the most sorrowful way.

Katsuki tried to push forward—but then a small, single tear drop fell from Izuku's eye.

Time split again. Then he froze.

Because he realized, the face beneath him was the same one that once laughed on a boat with him in Okinawa. The same one that peeked up over a book in the hotel bed. The same one that leaned close over steaming cups in Biei, whispering something dumb and gentle just to make him smile.

Those versions of Izuku bled into each other, like light refracted through stained glass.

And then finally, he saw the Izuku with the eyepatch.

He felt those caring, tiny hands on his shoulder again, washing away all the neglect he'd collected.

Katsuki's hands began to shake.

His grip loosened.

Air slammed into Izuku's lungs like concrete bricks hitting his chest. He began violently coughing. His hands instinctively flew to his throat as wind filled him up again. His trembling fingers landed on top of Katsuki's.

Katsuki gritted his teeth—angry with himself.

He thought of his mother's corpse and reached for his blade—he swung it towards Izuku's neck for the kill.

In a split second, Izuku caught sight of it. He closed his eyes and craned his neck, giving Katsuki the perfect opening.

Katsuki froze. The tip of his blade stopped at Izuku's Adam's apple.

Shock rippled across his body like hands splitting his spine. He watched with earth shattering realization, as yet again, Izuku remained giving—even now.

When he didn't make a move, Izuku hesitantly opened his eyes.

Katsuki's hands began shaking more—and soon the trembling became uncontrollable. His tears betrayed him as they poured from his eyes faster now. He tried to rid the roaring memories of Izuku out of his head, but he was unable to.

All the versions of Izuku's smile bombarded him like vicious lashes to the face. Over and over and over. His memory reminded him just how much he loved the man he had at knife point.

Katsuki's nose flared and he pushed his mother's corpse to the front of his mind. He could do it. He could fucking do it—but he stayed rooted like time stilled.

His eyes darted all around Izuku's face, cataloging every freckle he kissed in the past.

Suddenly, Izuku held Katsuki's shaking hand. He steadied the blade.

"It's yours to take, Kacchan," Izuku whispered through his quivering lips. "It's always been yours anyways."

Izuku didn't flinch. He didn't fight. He closed his eyes, tilted his head more, and offered his neck to Katsuki.

Katsuki's eyes widened as Izuku tried to help. But his hand couldn't move. He shook more violently and clenched his jaw. And it was at this moment Katsuki realized something horrifying: even after everything, Izuku still loved him enough to die by his hand.

He exploded.

Every blistering emotion erupted at once. Katsuki screamed out a loud, frustrated curse. He snatched the knife away from Izuku's throat and his body rocked forward.

Katsuki clenched his teeth as he lodged the knife into the floor next to Izuku's ear.

Izuku stared wide eyed in shock at Katsuki. He stared right back with the same emotion.

Katsuki watched, entirely helpless, as his tears steadily fell down onto Izuku. Soon, Izuku began to cry as well, and their sorrow mixed together on freckled skin.

"I—I *can't*." Katsuki's voice broke straight down the middle. "I *c-can't* do it."

Katsuki's face twisted in disbelief.

He gripped the blade's handle like it was the only thing anchoring him to the world. His fingers curled around the carved letters of his mother's name, as if the feel of it could give him strength—but it didn't. It only deepened the divide.

He was torn between love and hate. Guilt and rage. Duty and desire. He struggled back and forth, held prisoner by the two loud wolves inside of him.

In that moment, the beasts finally tore into each other. The warring halves that'd fought for dominance since he saw that red folder collided in one final clash. And the one who came out on top wasn't who he expected.

It was grief.

It had been sitting there, puppeteering everything from the shadows. It was draped in years of sadness and strife that Katsuki never got the time to process. Katsuki's face crumpled when it rose to its full height, showing itself.

He took one, good look into those eyes he loved so much. Suddenly all his rage was gone.

He screwed his eyes shut and turned his head away. He choked out several, muffled cries as he bit his lip.

Then Katsuki hunched over Izuku, weeping. He rested their foreheads together.

All the anger inside of him evaporated into the air. In its wake was only grief and mourning. The two sat heavy at the bottom of his body. They were dragging him down and he couldn't lift his limbs. Katsuki lowered his head into the crook of Izuku's neck and his free hand threaded through Izuku's hair tenderly.

"Wh-Why can't I d-do it?" Katsuki cried as he clutched the handle of his blade tighter.

As he held Izuku, the answer came to him. That tiny voice he'd been ignoring finally spoke up. It was no longer small but rather a loud, thunderous bellow that shook him to his core.

"Because you love him," it said. "Because you've *always* loved him."

The voice showed him all the different versions of Izuku. And he didn't know which versions of Izuku he loved more: the ones who fought him tooth and nail, or the ones who trusted him enough to fall asleep at his side.

"You love all of him," the voice said. "You won't be able to choose."

And the voice was right. All those different Izukus he loved.

Even the one who killed his mother.

All the years of denial caught up in one, swift moment. The tidal wave inside of him slammed down, hard and cruel and drowned him in the truth: it'd been love at first sight in Vienna and it stuck with him this whole time.

Suddenly, warm loving arms encased him.

Izuku, even after being hunted, was sweet to him again.

Katsuki broke down.

Izuku hugged him, giving him the embrace he so desperately wanted since finding that red folder.

Katsuki leaned into his husband and for this single moment, he felt small again. He missed his mother, and he missed his husband in the same, terrible breath. He cradled Izuku's head tenderly like he used to, not so long ago.

Suddenly, all he wanted was to go back to those few months in Biei. Just them. Happy. Nothing but pure, amazing happiness. Why couldn't he ever be happy like that? All he ever wanted was that type of steady peace in his life.

Katsuki held on tighter.

Izuku didn't say a word. The other man let him cry and some part of Katsuki despised it.

Of course the one person to witness his breakdown would be the same man who ruined him.

The tears came hard and fast. Then slower. Then finally, not at all.

Katsuki hated every second of it. Hated the way he shook. Hated the rawness clawing at his throat. Hated that he was sobbing into the neck of the man who'd destroyed his life. But more than anything, he hated the truth that wormed its way to the surface.

He didn't want to kill Izuku.

That fury he'd been feeding on lied to him. It dressed itself up as justice and closure. It told him that Izuku's blood would settle the score. A simple bullet through the skull or a knife between the ribs could set him free.

But now, with his face buried in the shoulder of the man who shattered him, he felt nothing but the weight of his own confusion. And the slow, sick realization that he still wanted Izuku.

Katsuki raised his head. Their noses brushed. His breath caught. Their eyes met and their extremely vulnerable gazes held.

A split second of silence.

This near, Katsuki couldn't deny Izuku's power over him. Izuku was close to being his everything. His husband. His prey. The man he always chased until he was fucking losing it in the head.

Because while Katsuki was always stronger, and Izuku was always faster, they were undeniably weak for each other—in every way.

His stomach tightened with the need to be closer to his other half and there was a pure, carnal pulse in his veins. It stirred awake from the visceral stare Izuku was giving him, and his mind began to crave being close.

Katsuki watched as Izuku let out a beautiful, unsteady breath.

Viridian eyes dilated, pulling Katsuki in like a siren song.

Katsuki tightened his grip on Izuku's hair. Izuku's fingers dug into his shoulders. Their breaths quickened together at a gradually increasing rate.

Then they both closed their eyes right as Katsuki lowered his head and Izuku tilted his head up.

They locked into a vicious kiss and all sanity walked out the door.

The kiss tasted like blood, sweat and tears. The three melted in a way that was only saved for them. Purely Izuku and Katsuki, colliding yet again in a taboo moment. Dark desire flooded through Katsuki as he began to take Izuku apart, pouring out all his frustrations.

What happened next, Katsuki couldn't have predicted in a thousand years.

It was provoked by Izuku's damning green eyes. The way Izuku watched him was as if Katsuki was danger personified, and Izuku wanted to get hurt. The stare was maddening, pulling Katsuki further and further away from all his senses.

Their hands scratched into each other until there was no distance left between them.

Katsuki's heart skipped a beat when Izuku called his name, soaked in sultry want. Right then and there, the ground felt like it would give way underneath him if he didn't take Izuku. Katsuki worked his knife in a way that called to all sides of him.

Izuku's eyes followed the blade as if in a trance.

He cut away all of Izuku's clothes, egged on by his husband's hungry stare. When Izuku was helplessly naked beneath him, Katsuki admired the blood spots across Izuku's skin. All the new cuts and bruises were like a painting, and they smeared across his freckles beautifully.

Izuku's gaze was equal parts worship and self-destruction. It beckoned to him: wreck me, take me, unload it all on me.

So Katsuki did.

He sat up and snapped his shirt off in one fluid motion. Then he surrendered to all his feelings.

He fluidly bound his husband with the zip ties he meant to use to trap him—and Izuku willingly gave his wrists without a struggle. He was staring at Katsuki like he was ready to be burned, and willingly ready to receive every inch of Katsuki's cock and fury.

When Katsuki pushed inside his husband, he knew that they would be forever bound in a way that no one could name.

He desecrated Izuku with all the powerful emotions strung between them.

Hate. Love. Rapture. Envy. Jealousy. Pain.

He weaponized each one into powerful thrusts. He wanted Izuku to feel every ounce of his exasperation—and he felt Izuku's right back. Even in zip ties, his husband's nails dug into him. Every ounce of themselves was given in that moment and swelled together into a ruthless fucking.

Underneath every moan was a bloody vow. Every squeeze of the neck was a promise. Katsuki kept his mouth busy until Izuku forgot how to tremble. It was mind numbing. Katsuki could feel Izuku melt around him like he was wax over Katsuki's flame.

Then Izuku gasped. Katsuki felt it, a spasm that told him that Izuku was his and only his.

Not Chisaki's. Not death's. But *his*.

That split-second moment when his cock hit Izuku's sweet spot, Katsuki decided it was only for him to touch. He angled and pounded relentlessly until Izuku shattered. Pleasure tore through them like a scream beneath skin.

Katsuki pressed bites to Izuku's spine that matched the way he started to move. Fully rough, hard, and relentless. He sped up, grinding into Izuku until he tore moans of electric heat from his husband.

He fucked Izuku like this was his vengeance—and maybe it was.

He devoured Izuku whole, nipping and sucking until he felt Izuku struggle against the zip ties, curls bouncing too lovely for a vulgar moment like this. Every thrust Katsuki gave was a promise made with teeth. And Izuku took it, willingly. He took all of Katsuki, moaning like it hurt to feel this good.

Their rhythm turned punishing. Katsuki drove into him like he was trying to leave pieces of himself behind. Izuku fucked back like he was starving, like the only way he could feel whole again was to have Katsuki demolish him.

When Izuku came the first time, Katsuki didn't stop.

Not even when he came again, screaming his name, Katsuki still didn't stop.

It was the third that broke him.

Izuku's whole body convulsed, raw and sobbing. They came together and Katsuki emptied everything he was into his husband. That final thrust cracked both of their hearts wide open. Emotions bled out of Izuku like floodwater breaching a dam. Izuku cried like it wasn't sex but rather like it was a resurrection.

Katsuki wrapped his arms around him, held him through the powerful orgasm. And when Izuku shook in his arms—completely blind, breathless, and ruined—Katsuki finally understood what it meant to be needed like this. To be worshipped. To be wholly loved so much that he felt the power surge down to his core.

And he couldn't get enough.

Without pulling out, Katsuki rolled their bodies to the middle of the bed and pressed Izuku belly down. Izuku's head hit the soft pillow as he breathed steadily in and out, sweat rolling down all parts of his body.

"We're very far from done, Deku," Katsuki roughly hissed against the shell of Izuku's ear. He rolled his hips in a slow, greedy grind that made Izuku's eyes fall shut with pleasure. "Bite a pillow if you need to."

They kept going. One round. Two rounds.

They even tore through to a sixth, impossible one when Izuku rolled their bodies and he wound up on top, straddling Katsuki.

Izuku trembled like he was caught somewhere between need and delirium. Sweat slicked his skin, and his thighs shook as he rode Katsuki like he couldn't get enough of the cock stuffing him full.

Katsuki's back was flush against the mattress, feet planted for leverage. He fucked up into Izuku with powerful force. He was trying to demolish him from the inside out and fill the man with all his pent up emotions.

He dragged Izuku down into a kiss that was all teeth, tongue and insatiable hunger.

Izuku whimpered into it, helpless. His bound hands clawed at Katsuki's chest, leaving scratches that burned deliciously. Katsuki groaned as Izuku's mouth found his neck, sucking hard enough to bruise. Then he started out right crying, lost in too much pleasure.

He pressed his lips directly against Katsuki's, trembling.

"Ka-Kacchan," Izuku sobbed, sounding like he was gone from all his sanity. He began to struggle against his zip ties, and made a frustrated sound. "Kacchan, Please. I *need*—"

"—Then *take*," Katsuki growled furiously.

He bit down on Izuku's lip unkindly, drawing blood.

Izuku gasped, cried out, but didn't pull away. He only ground harder against him, shivering as Katsuki's grip bruised into his hips and his cock slammed deeper with every thrust.

Izuku's body bucked and shook, biceps flexing as he fought against the plastic ties. And then, with a fierce, guttural groan, he tore them apart at the same time Katsuki slammed against his prostate. Izuku threw his arms around Katsuki's neck as if he'd been craving holding him all along.

Katsuki's hands dropped low, spreading Izuku's cheeks open with no shame. He drove up into him until the bed groaned beneath them.

Izuku was panting like an animal in heat. He sat up, back arched and cock leaking against Katsuki's stomach. His trembling hands gripped the headboard as he rode Katsuki with a fire that bordered on madness.

His hair was clinging to his forehead, soaked with sweat. Blood was smeared across his lips, his chest, his fingertips. And his eyes—*fuck*, those sweet doe eyes—were pitch-black with lust, pupils blown so wide they swallowed the green whole.

He looked like pure sin, like some forbidden god that came down to ruin Katsuki.

And Katsuki fucking loved it.

“That’s it,” he growled loudly, voice breaking as Izuku bounced on him relentlessly. “Take it. Fucking take it all you want.”

Izuku rode him with force that knocked the air straight from Katsuki’s lungs. The slap of skin filled the room, lewd and thunderous, punctuated only by Izuku’s strangled moans every time Katsuki’s cock hit that spot inside him.

Katsuki matched him, thrust for thrust. His hands left bruises on Izuku’s cheeks and his nostrils flared with how deep his need was. His logic was gone—burned to white-hot noise that sang one command: fill Izuku up with everything he could.

Izuku beautifully moaned his name when Katsuki fingered at his already stuffed hole without warning.

The bed creaked loudly.

With help from the slick lube and cum, Katsuki sunk the finger inside. He stretched Izuku’s hole wider, and felt himself deliciously sucked in. Izuku’s movements became more desperate as he pushed another finger in. Then Izuku outright began sobbing from overstimulation when he did a third. But still, Izuku didn’t stop.

He kept riding Katsuki as he pushed in a fourth finger, making Izuku take a new limit of being filled up.

Katsuki grinned, feral, as he watched Izuku fuck himself on his cock and fingers.

Then, the bed cracked.

The whole frame flipped, breaking underneath their debauchery. Both their eyes widened, and their breaths caught as they were tossed ungracefully to the floor. The sheets went with them, and Katsuki quickly wrapped his arms around Izuku, keeping himself buried to the hilt.

They hit the ground with Izuku’s back on the floor, Katsuki between his legs and the covers over their heads.

There was barely time to register the new position because immediately Izuku grabbed his face and began to kiss him deeply. The metallic taste of iron exchanged between them. Katsuki couldn’t help but lick the blood from off Izuku’s bottom lip.

His husband gasped at the sensation and excitedly clenched around Katsuki’s throbbing length.

“Don’t stop,” Izuku commanded breathlessly.

He wrapped his muscular legs around Katsuki’s waist, locking him in.

They fixed gazes and Katsuki was gone.

Katsuki fisted Izuku’s cock and started to fuck him with all the wrath he never got to scream.

Every thrust was brutal and honest. He wanted to ruin him. Make his husband feel him tomorrow, the next week and *forever*. And Izuku met his thrusts like he craved the savageness of it. Slick, wet sounds of lube and cum filled their ears as he railed Izuku into the ground.

Katsuki watched Izuku come undone, blissfully crying out with wrecked sounds that made his cock throb harder. He sucked at Izuku’s neck and nails raked down his back.

When pain bloomed across his skin, Katsuki accepted the truth in all its heaviness. No matter how much blood soaked the floor between them, he would always choose to crawl through it —just to be with his husband.

Because even though he was a monster, he was a monster that loved Izuku.

☽ ☽ ☽

By the time they were tired, the sky was beginning to brighten.

They were pushed past their limits and both of their voices were hoarse. Every ounce of adrenaline in their bodies had been spent. And it resulted in hours of sex that Katsuki couldn’t get enough of. He could kiss Izuku forever, he dangerously realized.

When they finally stopped, it was abrupt.

Izuku moaned loudly after dry orgasming for the nth time. His voice cracked exquisitely and his back arched off the floor. His legs quaked as Katsuki emptied deep inside of him.

Izuku gasped sharply, then his whole body collapsed with Katsuki’s.

His hands were still clutching at Katsuki’s shoulders with what little strength he had. Then they fell away. His eyes fluttered, and for a second he seemed like he might try to fight the weight pulling him under. But it won. Izuku gave in completely to sleep right then and there.

A faint snore slipped past Izuku’s lips.

Katsuki stared in shock.

“Izuku?” He questioned.

But no answer came.

He lifted his fingers to check for a pulse, and found it was steady and fine. He couldn't stop the sense of bewilderment. Had they really fucked until Izuku passed out?

He blinked slowly, staggered by the sudden come down. Then, with a low grunt, he pulled out. He tried his best to be slow and careful, wincing at the wet pop that followed. He rolled to his feet, ignoring the pain in his arm from where Izuku shot him. It throbbed sharply, but he pushed it aside to tend to Izuku first.

He walked to the bathroom and returned a moment later with a warm, damp towel.

Wordlessly, Katsuki knelt beside Izuku.

He began to clean him. He carefully dragged the rag across Izuku's forehead, ridding him of the salty sweat gluing his hair to his face. Then he moved lower, trailing the cloth down over Izuku's chest, his thighs, his calves, and eventually the mess between his legs.

Izuku softly whined in his sleep as Katsuki cleaned his entrance, jerking slightly.

The helplessness of the sound made his heart tug.

He looked down, and saw the absurd amount of cum spilling from Izuku.

He probed his tongue at his cheek. It would be unpleasant if Izuku woke up with that much fluid dried inside of him. And it would take forever to get out if left overnight.

Katsuki rolled Izuku over, belly down.

Then he put his head between Izuku's legs. He spread Izuku's backside, getting a good look at the overused entrance. It was pink, swollen and the rim was twitching. He thought about using his fingers to scoop out the cum, but knew his softest appendage would avoid more irritation.

He hesitated for only a second before leaning in.

The first press of his tongue was measured and gentle.

Izuku quietly groaned in his sleep, hips twitching faintly. Katsuki pushed his tongue in further, moving it gingerly and drew out all of the cum. He swallowed it down and spread Izuku's legs further. Izuku whined again when Katsuki softly swirled his tongue. He ate it all until there was nothing left.

He pulled back and spread Izuku's backside so he could see the little hole again. He ran the rag over it a final time, cleaning all the remains.

He walked over to his bag and unzipped the side pocket. His fingers brushed past gauze and tape until they closed around the small bottle of emergency ointment tucked inside his travel first aid kit. When he returned to Izuku, he smeared it across any scrapes, cuts, and bruises he could find along the other man. Then mindfully he put a generous amount on Izuku's entrance.

After he was done, Katsuki leaned in and planted a kiss against the small of Izuku's back.

He continued on cleaning Izuku's arms, his hands, his legs—until there was nothing left but a man who'd been thoroughly, intimately cared for.

When he was done, Katsuki tossed the rag into the corner of the room and sank down beside him. He pulled the covers over them and used the last of his strength to turn his head.

Izuku looked peaceful.

And that was the last thing he remembered before sleep finally took him.

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki was falling again. He didn't want to be. But he was dragged through his mind like a body being pulled over a barbed wire. Blackness swept over his thoughts and brought him back to another distant memory.

This time, he was nineteen. One year earlier than the dream he had of her before.

It was early spring, everyone was coming off the coattails of winter. Hope was in the air as people were excited to get outside and stretch their limbs after such a long hibernation.

But more importantly, it was his birthday.

They were at his mother's apartment. The windows were open and the air that drifted in was warm and damp with rain. The scent of pavement and wet cherry blossoms cut through the scorched mess wafting out of the kitchen.

Katsuki woke up from a nap to the smell of food burning. For a second, he thought the house was on fire—*again*.

He stormed into the kitchen, ready to yell, but froze when he saw her.

His mother was sweating over a cake pan like it was a live grenade. The kitchen looked like a bomb went off in it. Flour was on the floor. A scorch mark was on the side of the toaster. One of her sleeves was singed at the edge.

She didn't even look at him when she pointed at the cake on the counter with her spatula.

"Happy birthday, brat."

It was the most hideous cake Katsuki had ever seen. It was pink, lopsided and sagged like it was barely holding on. Red frosting pooled like blood on one side. And more so, strawberries were squashed flat into the surface into a sloppy letter K.

Katsuki blinked.

"Since when did you cook?" He asked, scrunching his nose. "This looks a mess."

“Yeah? So does your face,” she snapped. Her hair was tied back with a rubber band, and there was a streak of frosting down her jaw. “I wanted to try to do something nice for you. I realized I never properly said sorry for how your sixteenth birthday went, so here—happy birthday, Katsuki.”

Like the good son he was, Katsuki sat down.

His mother stuck a single pink candle into the top with unnecessary force and lit it with her cigarette lighter. He stared at the crooked flame. She crossed her arms like she was daring him not to eat it.

“You’re not getting another one. I don’t care if it tastes like shit.”

Katsuki scoffed a bit, then smiled.

He blew out his candle, happy to make a wish.

This was the first time she’d gone out of her way to bake a cake. He wondered if she did this out of guilt since she mentioned his badly bungled sixteenth birthday.

But, to him, this was great.

He faked liking the cake even though the bottom was burned. The middle was also half raw and the frosting was too sweet. But he didn’t say a word. He ate it like it was the best thing he’d ever tasted. Because her knuckles were scraped, her voice was tired, and her smile flickered when she thought he wasn’t looking.

“Thanks, this is awesome,” Katsuki said.

“You’re welcome,” his mom replied with a grin. “Happy birthday, you brat.”

She ruffled his hair without saying another word. Her palm was warm and dusted with sugar. Outside, a breeze moved through the open window and stirred the curtains. It carried the smell of earth and rain and the distant sound of someone cutting grass.

“What did you wish for?” His mom asked.

He shrugged. “Nothing serious.”

But that was a lie. He wished for more moments like these. He could finally see his mother coming around the corner, and he was so happy about it. He could see her attempting to be there for him in ways she wasn’t when he was younger.

He wished for her to continue being better.

☽ ☽ ☽

Day After Reuniting

When Katsuki woke up, he was no longer in his mother's apartment. Instead, he was thrusted back into the reality where his mother didn't get to live to her full potential. And one of the men responsible was next to him, naked in the covers.

Katsuki groaned from the jarring whiplash.

They were laying on the ground, tangled in a heap of bedding. His muscles were screaming from the insane marathon of sex they endured.

He looked around the motel and was impressed with the wreckage. Glass shards glittered across the carpet like a field of broken stars, remnants of the mirror Katsuki shattered. All the pictures were knocked off the walls and fractured on the ground. The bed had been rocked halfway across the room and it was tilting downwards from when they broke it.

Pretty much, the room was obliterated.

Shamefully, Katsuki got up.

He walked over to his bag, and sifted inside for the first aid kit. He found it and returned to sit on the floor beside Izuku. He began to dress his new gun shot wound that was pulsating.

As he did this, he studied Izuku.

His anger was gone, replaced by its true face: hurt. His sadness was more powerful now, and the undeniable love he held for Izuku was plain as day. He couldn't hold back the pathetic sigh that fell from his lips.

How stupid he was for thinking he fell in love with Izuku during Biei.

He's probably been in love from the moment he laid eyes on him in Vienna.

The irony. The guy who hated romance fell victim to love at first sight at the age of seventeen and never recovered.

Katsuki finished cleaning his wound and sat upright against the wall.

All the screws in his head that had come undone last night retightened. He began thinking straight again, focusing on what the hell was he going to do now to get his revenge. He chewed on his bottom lip as he swallowed down the new epiphany: he couldn't kill Izuku—and he didn't want to. But that contradicted everything he'd been living for these last five years.

Slowly, Izuku stirred.

His hair was disheveled and a small grunt left him as he rose. Izuku glanced around with those doe eyes of his, looking far too innocent for the killing machine he was. He sleepily rubbed his face and tried to sit upright. He immediately winced. Izuku gasped, groaned, then rolled himself up with one arm on his side.

He looked at Katsuki wearily.

Katsuki hung his head away.

Another memory of his mother came then—her in her casket. Her pale lifeless face an ashen grey. He could still remember how the mortician tried to cover up the gunshot holes in her temples with her hair. But it only half worked. He could see the wounds as they lowered her to the ground.

Katsuki raked a hand through his hair and gripped the roots hard enough to sting.

He was truly fucking *weak*.

He glanced at Izuku once, then slowly stood up from the covers. He shifted tiredly and kicked the sheets off to the side. He began putting on his clothes in humiliation. He kept his back turned towards Izuku as he halfway dressed in his shirt and boxers.

Then he leaned against the wall across the way from where Izuku was. Katsuki put distance between them. If he didn't, he knew he would embrace Izuku again.

Izuku was studying him carefully with some distrust in his eyes.

The sound of a rustling tree reached both of their ears.

Quickly, Izuku—who was visibly on edge—hastily looked out the window. Then when he noticed it was only trees, the paranoia washed away, but Izuku's jumpy demeanor didn't leave. He stiffened as if he was afraid of someone else.

If what Shigaraki said was true, then Katsuki knew who Izuku was afraid of. But Katsuki wanted Izuku to confirm it in case Shigaraki was lying.

"So," Katsuki said. He cleared his throat, put his head down, and nervously toyed with his hands. "Who else are you running from besides me that has you this jumpy?"

"I-I'm likely being hunted by both the Shie Hassaikai and my family now," Izuku confessed, but then cringed. He tilted his head and made a small correction, "Rather, the people who used to be my family, I suppose. The Viper Academy. Both are possibly coming for me."

"What did you do for that to happen?"

Izuku paused.

Then he said, "I stopped an order of the Shie Hassaikai. And in the process, I slaughtered a large chunk of other assassins from my academy. I haven't run into either the Yakuza or Vipers yet but…it's only a matter of time."

Much to Katsuki's surprise, Izuku confirmed Shigaraki was telling the truth. However, Shigaraki didn't mention Izuku murdering some of his own at all. He found the omission odd, but figured maybe Shigaraki was giving him the footnotes version.

"What constitutes a large chunk?" Katsuki asked distantly.

“Over twenty of my siblings.”

At that, Katsuki balked. He whipped his head up, entirely surprised by the number he heard.

“*Twenty*?” Katsuki parroted.

Izuku nodded slowly.

Katsuki added those bodies to his own kill count that same night. He raised his brows. Between the two of them, they’d slain over sixty people in under a day. He couldn’t help but feel morbidly impressed with their handiwork.

“I-I didn’t know many of them,” Izuku amended, distressed. “My unit was always sectioned off from everyone. But I had to kill three from my unit who I was close with the same night of the masquerade. My older brother, older sister, and my favorite brother, who I thought might be capable of saving. But he wasn’t.”

Katsuki’s eyes stretched wide.

Older brother? Izuku finally killed his abusive brother?

All the years passed in front of Katsuki.

He recalled the ugly bruises Izuku would come with. Then sourly, Katsuki recalled the eight years they were at odds. He still remembered when Izuku arrived to kill the Midnight Butcher. His face was pulverized, lip split down the middle.

Katsuki tightened his grip on his hands to keep from hugging Izuku.

He was overjoyed that Izuku killed his abuser. Good fucking riddance.

“What made you snap like that?” Katsuki whispered.

Izuku looked Katsuki seriously in the eye now. Katsuki felt his heart tug, and all those strong emotions for Izuku amplified.

“At the masquerade, five of the people you killed were members of the Chisaki family,” Izuku informed him, and Katsuki’s only thought was ‘*good*’. “That set off a chain reaction and I had no choice but to intervene.”

“What kind of chain reaction?”

“A deadly one. Chisaki Kai is *furious* about his family members being killed, Katsuki. He figured out you did the massacre and wanted to even the score with the traditional Yakuza punishment: a life for a life. A family member for a family member. But you don’t have any family. Except—”

Izuku paused, sucked in a breath and reluctantly pointed to himself.

“—Me. Legally.”

At this Katsuki grew confused. “We’re not related.”

“Our, ah, *marriage*,” Izuku muttered with a light blush. “It makes us legally family.”

“Oh.” Katsuki sparked with realization. He nodded slowly. “Right. We’re family. Legally.”

“The marriage certificate was on the public records, and he found it,” Izuku continued to explain. “Because of that, he jumped to the conclusion I had a helping hand in plotting to kill his family and maybe other Vipers. He decided five Vipers had to be killed to balance the scales. A-And then my brother offered to kill the five kids we have.”

Katsuki’s stomach turned. “Who thinks of something like that?”

“Tomura.”

Izuku spat his brother’s name with so much resentment that Katsuki was taken back.

But he was damn glad to hear it.

“My big brother *Tomura* thinks of something like that,” Izuku hissed, fiercely. “And I-I couldn’t let that happen. I *couldn’t*. I would burn down the whole city of Tokyo before I ever let that happen. So, I killed them. I killed every single snake that stood in my way, got the kids and ran.”

“And where are the kids now?”

“They’re all safe with Nana,” Izuku explained sadly. “She’s taking them home to their families. I-I had luckily found her rather quickly thanks to your help. You, uh, figured out the bulk of the work and I just put in the last piece. Her alias was One For All. I tracked her down and we talked. Then she agreed to help reunite them with their families that they were stolen from. So, even if the Yakuza or Vipers find me, the kids will be safe no matter what.”

Katsuki’s eyes softened.

Izuku did it. He stopped his cycle.

Affection poured out of him like a steady river. He couldn’t stop it, even if he tried.

All he wanted to do was jump forward and kiss Izuku once more. This time kinder and deeper. He wanted to tell Izuku to be glad he stood up for himself, and not to feel any remorse for killing that bastard brother of his.

But the hurt from being betrayed kept him rooted in place.

“You did good,” Katsuki whispered slowly. He squeezed his hands together and gave a pained, short nod. “I’m…I’m really proud of you.”

“Thank you,” Izuku replied quietly.

They held gazes for a long moment.

Love pulled fiercely inside of him, begging him to run across the room.

Forcefully, Katsuki blinked back oncoming tears. He pushed the heel of his hand into his watery eye and then hung his head down. His hair shadowed his face as he went back to fidgeting. The broken heart inside of him weighed too much.

“But—Katsuki. That’s not all,” Izuku suddenly said. “You’re in danger too.”

Katsuki scoffed and shook his head tiredly. “I’ll be fine.”

“No, Katsuki,” Izuku warned. “You won’t be. Chisaki very explicitly demanded he wants you *killed* for what you did at the Masquerade. Chisaki kills people who harm his family in creative ways. He’s the head of the Shie Hassaikai for a reason. He overhauled seven other Yakuza families and absorbed them into his own in a very violent, sadistic fashion. You need to be extremely careful. You’re in just as much danger as I am.”

Katsuki was offended.

Izuku really thought his latest, scummy lover was more skilled than him? As if.

He’d done away with gang leaders before without an issue. He could easily do it again, but he knew it was going to take time this turn. Chisaki being the Yakuza Heir put a large, solid barrier around him—but Katsuki was confident he could get past it. He could break it down with his bare fists because he *had* to.

If he didn’t, his pain would corrode him from the inside.

“Chisaki is the one that needs to be careful,” Katsuki grumbled under his breath. “I’m more capable than you think.” He sighed. Then shifted again. “Well. What is your next move, Izuku?”

“I guess I’m going to keep it moving,” Izuku confessed in a small voice. “Um, Nana offered me a spot to go with her. She said she could help me get out permanently, like you wanted me to do originally. B-But that won’t be for another two months.”

There was a long pause.

“Are you going to take it?” Katsuki asked.

“I-I’m halfway considering it,” Izuku whispered honestly. “That’s my only option if I want to live an okay life, right? I can’t go back to Tokyo, and I have nowhere else to go. Especially after all the killings I’ve done, I likely need protecting to cover up my past. Th-There’s no place for me anymore.”

At that, Katsuki soured once more.

After all the ‘killings’ he’s done?

Izuku said it so simply, like the damage he caused Katsuki was a drop in the ocean. It was almost like Izuku didn’t give a fuck about killing his mother. Katsuki’s mixed emotions

stirred again, twisting his insides like putty.

He kept his face as stale as possible as he said his next words.

“Are you sure?” Katsuki asked. His voice was low and quiet. “That’s what you want to do?”

Izuku took a long pause. “I think it is.”

Katsuki waited.

And waited.

And then he waited some more.

He waited for fucking *something*. Any sort of mention about his mother’s death, or a sorry about how much hurt Izuku caused. He waited for Izuku to say something about deceiving him for a full month. Or poisoning him and leaving him alone. He even waited for an explanation about Izuku being with Chisaki directly after being with him.

But Izuku uttered not a single word.

And it broke his goddamn heart.

He got it now, Izuku loved him. But he didn’t care as much as he thought. So why should Katsuki? He was proud of Izuku for killing his abuser—but Izuku still killed his mother. And Katsuki made a promise at her funeral to get justice. No matter what.

He had one more option left that didn’t involve killing Izuku—and it was the burner phone in his backpack.

Katsuki tightened the grip on his hands as guilt began to chew away at him.

“Okay,” Katsuki whispered. “Let me help you then.”

Katsuki kept his head down as he deceived Izuku.

He did this because he knew now, Izuku was his ultimate weakness. If he continued to gaze into those beautiful eyes, for even a *second*, he would be done for. His resolve would crumble—and he didn’t want that.

“R-Really?” Izuku whispered, perking up. “You want to help me?”

“Yeah,” Katsuki lied. He wrung his hands tighter. “Just lay low for two months, right? We can figure out a way to stay out of sight together. I can withdraw some cash to help us go dark and I have my motorcycle we can get around on easily. It’ll be safer with the two of us rather than you trying to do this alone.”

More tears pushed at his eyes when ugliness twisted around him.

The side of him that loved Izuku was weeping.

He didn't like lying to Izuku, and this pained him so much to do—but he needed to do it if he wanted to finally move on from his mother's death.

"Thank you, Katsuki," Izuku said gratefully. "Nana gave me the address for a place I could stay at in the meantime. It's called Midnight Sento, it's in a small town not too terribly far from here. It's a bathhouse run by someone she knows who can house us."

"This is nice of her," Katsuki muttered.

He pursed his lips and tilted his head as he thought of a believable lie.

The one he came up with was simple. Once upon a time Aizawa mentioned a 'safe house' that The Company kept for people in witness protection programs. It was super discreet and used to house their more endangered clientele.

He decided to take that and run with it.

"But realistically," he continued. "You're going to need better security than laying low at a bathhouse. If you're going to stay out of their hands for two whole months, you need protection. Likely from trained, lethal bodyguards. I know my ex-supervisor has a safe harbor not too far from here. You'll be better protected in a place with other hitmen who are trained similarly to me."

Izuku didn't respond back right away. Katsuki could tell he was taking a beat to think about things, weighing his options.

"Would your ex-supervisor be okay with me using his safe house?" Izuku asked nervously. "Last I checked your old company also had a kill order on me."

"I'm sure that's settled by now. But if it's not, I'll just beg him," Katsuki grumbled, lying flawlessly. "The old man has a soft spot for me."

"Thank you so much, Katsuki. But what are you going to do? I know you think you can take on Chisaki head on, but he has a lot of connections all over Japan. Getting close to him isn't going to be a simple thing—and neither is getting away. Y-You might need Nana's help disappearing too now," Izuku suggested meekly. "It's something you should consider."

At another mention of that bastard, Katsuki bristled immediately.

"The only thing I am considering is killing Chisaki," Katsuki snapped back harshly. "You don't need to worry about me, Izuku. I can handle myself just fine. I've taken care of myself my whole life. The only thing you need to worry about is laying low. So. Let's get a move on to that safe house."

"Okay," Izuku replied quietly. "Thank you again for being willing to help."

"Don't mention it."

Katsuki reached over into his backpack and pulled out the navy-blue burner Shigaraki gave him.

“I’ll be right back. I’m going to go make the call to get us set up,” Katsuki muttered distantly. “Start getting ready to head out.”

“O-Okay.”

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki walked around the corner, far away from the room.

He stared at the phone like it was a real Mamushi snake. He was waiting for it to come alive and bite him in the neck—but that was a chance he was willing to take. He reflected on how much lack of remorse Izuku showed about his mother. It was fucking repulsive.

But at least now, Katsuki knew if he did give Izuku back, his abusive brother wouldn’t be there because he was dead.

In a way, that made Katsuki feel more content.

He flipped open the phone and pressed dial. It only took one, single ring for Shigaraki to answer.

“Bakugou,” Shigaraki greeted, sounding only a touch surprised. “I thought for a second there you had thrown away the phone after dismantling the wire tap.”

“Is the deal still on the table?” Katsuki asked, cutting right to the point.

“Yes it is.” There was a smug level of amusement in his voice. “Changed your mind?”

“Nearly,” Katsuki replied tightly. “Give me details on how you plan to give me a shot at Chisaki.”

“I’ll schedule a false deal in a remote location,” Shigaraki explained, the ease in his tone grating. “After the power transfer is done, I’ll have full control over his security detail. That means I choose who’s on-site. I’ll choose only Viper agents—no Yakuza.”

Katsuki said nothing, letting the silence push Shigaraki to keep talking.

“Vipers don’t ask questions. They’re loyal to me,” he went on. “So when I give the signal, you come in and do what you’ve been dying to do. We’ll turn our backs. No interference. No cameras. Just you and him. You carve him up, bury what’s left, and we walk away like it never happened.”

Katsuki sucked at his teeth.

That would be a perfect opportunity. An opening like this didn’t come around very often.

“Okay,” Katsuki grumbled after a long moment. “Now when and where would this be?”

“Potentially within the next year.”

Katsuki groaned loudly. “Are you fucking serious right now?”

“I know, it’s not ideal,” Shigaraki quickly explained. He softened his tone and tried to calm Katsuki down. “But killing the leader of the entire underground Yakuza syndicate takes time. You can’t simply rush into it without coming out with a bounty on your head—much like yours is right now.”

Katsuki felt like throwing this damn phone.

A *year*? Did this guy really think he was stupid?

“Bakugou,” Shigaraki said slowly, bringing down his anger. “If you give it at least six months, I can promise the hunt for you within the Yakuza will die down with my help from the inside. I’ll make sure Chisaki will be occupied with other things. And when he least expects it, we’ll strike. I want to make sure no harm comes to you.”

“As nice as that sounds, I know there has to be more,” Katsuki jeered. “You don’t seem like the altruistic type. So cough it up. What’s the real reason you want to wait a year?”

There was a long pause, as if Shigaraki wasn’t expecting Katsuki to guess his angle.

“Fine.” Shigaraki sighed, clearly aggravated. “Coupled with what I just said, I do need Chisaki alive to grant me power for a merger I am working on. I can only take over *after* he is dead and Vipers are melted deep into the Yakuza. But it would look suspicious to the Chisaki family if their Heir died directly after the merger. Ultimately, it would be a win-win for both of us to wait this out.”

Katsuki worked his jaw back and forth.

He’d waited for years to kill Chizome when he thought it was him. And truthfully, Shigaraki made logistical and logical points. It would be damn near impossible to get his hands around that crow like motherfucker’s neck given what he did at the masquerade.

Everyone was on high alert and if what Izuku said was true, then they knew he was the culprit.

It took a while, but ultimately, Katsuki decided he could wait a measly year. He could lay low. He could do that in the name of his mother.

“…And what would happen to Izuku during this time?” Katsuki asked softly, one more time.

“I told you, he would remain untouched,” Shigaraki explained. “I am planning to take him off all assignments after this.”

“How come?”

“You sure like to ask questions.”

“I like to know exactly what I am signing up for,” Katsuki quipped. “So tell me. How come? If Izuku is your most valuable asset as you say, then why would you be taking him off

assignments?"

"I'm taking him off because I don't think he's well suited for assignments any longer," Shigaraki admitted. The tone of his voice was heavy with what seemed like regret. "His outburst proves it. I've been pushing him too hard. When you bring him back, I will retire him. We have enough money that he wouldn't need to go find a job, so he would live out the rest of his days in comfort and luxury. Exactly as he always has been."

Katsuki's eyes dropped to the floor. That didn't sound so bad.

"That's it?" He whispered.

"That's it," Shigaraki confirmed.

He sat on it.

He imagined Izuku's life back home would be different now. Izuku wouldn't be forced to kill. He would be in that mansion pampered with endless books to read. He would cry over Katsuki's betrayal but he would cry in his Rolls-Royce.

And he'd never have to flinch from the sound of his older brother's footsteps again—because at least now, the bastard was dead.

Izuku's life would be okay. And after Katsuki killed Chisaki, so would his.

"Alright," Katsuki murmured, feeling inexplicably filthy. "I'll agree to bring Izuku back to you, but only if you make it six months instead of one year. Then you have a deal."

"Fine. We can make it six months."

And just like that, his deal with the devil was struck.

He felt the invisible handshake come and take a piece of his soul with it. The side of him that loved Izuku was lashing out, recklessly thrashing trying to get a grip on him. But the memory of cradling his mother's cold, dead body for hours prevented it from doing so.

"Where should I meet you to drop off?" Katsuki asked solemnly. "I'm with him now in Osaka."

"The Viper Academy has a secondary location on Oshima Island," Shigaraki explained. "It's a couple hours south of you, but I will meet you there. There's a ferry that departs at the end of the day you can make if you're quick. I'll make sure the Yakuza and Vipers hold off on their search for you both."

"Got it. Once I get to the island, I demand we have this in writing of some sort."

"Of course," Shigaraki promised. "I'll make sure to draw up a proper contract before you and Izuku arrive."

"Good. We'll see you soon."

He closed the flip phone without saying goodbye.

He put it in his pocket the same time a single, cold tear rolled out of his eye. Quickly, he dragged the heel of his palm across his cheek and wiped away that sign of weakness before it could make him stray any further.

But with that tear, came a voice.

“Don’t do this!” It screamed. “Please! Don’t do this. You *love* him!”

It was the same voice from last night. However, he decided then to bury it deep. He dug a grave for it, right next to the grief he carried for his mother. Packed it in tight with dirt made of betrayal and silence. He suffocated that voice beneath all the hurt Izuku inflicted.

And he wanted that hurt gone. But the only way he could vanquish it was to get his revenge.

He repeated this to himself. Over and over until he believed it.

By the time he made his way back to the room, he convinced himself vengeance was the only way he could be truly happy.

☽ ☽ ☽

He told Izuku about the so-called ‘safe house’ on Oshima Island.

It was ironic how easily the lie fell into place. It sounded right. Like something that he would actually do if the deal with Shigaraki wasn’t on the table. And of course, Izuku didn’t question him. The other man simply nodded, fully trusting. It was damn near harrowing how trusting Izuku was.

And because of that, Katsuki couldn’t meet his eyes. Not because he was sad, but rather he wasn’t sure he could look into the eyes of the man he adored so much and still go through with betraying him.

How the hell had Izuku done it?

How the *fuck* did Izuku looked him in his face for thirty days and never say a single word?

It made him sick. Izuku managed to smile, laugh, and kiss him without flinching. And it was more than heart breaking. Because if Izuku could do all that while knowing what he’d done —then maybe he didn’t care at all.

Maybe knowing he’d killed Bakugou Mitsuki didn’t cost Izuku a single night of sleep.

As the motorcycle tore down the road, that last month in Biei replayed on a loop.

Each time he thought of a past memory, his ache deepened. He re-lived all the soft, stupid moments they’d shared like it was real—only to have it all poisoned under the new light.

☽ ☽ ☽

About an hour from the ferry, the road threw another goddamn obstacle in their path.

Because of *course* it did. Nothing in Katsuki's life ever comes easy, and today wasn't about to be the exception.

A tree collapsed across the highway. It dragged power lines down and crushed several cars beneath its weight like they were nothing but toys. Police were scattered across the scene, taping off the wreckage and waving cars back with stiff arms and hardened faces.

Katsuki tried his best to convince them to let them through. But not a single officer gave a shit. The cops stood their ground, unmoved by his words.

In the end, all he got was a redirection and a ticking clock.

And unfortunately, luck was not on his side. They ended up missing the ferry.

The moment they arrived, the boat took off. He groaned one loud curse into the wind. Angrily, he slammed the bike's kickstand down with the heel of his boot, jumped off and was ready to tear into anything just to feel like he had control again.

In contrast, Izuku said nothing. Simply pulled off his helmet and shook out his hair, slow and unbothered. He swung his legs off the bike and leaned back against it. He kept his gaze fixed on the fading outline of the ferry as it sailed away into the dark.

Katsuki snatched his own helmet off, and pulled out the burner phone.

His fingers flew over the buttons, unhappy that he was once again hitting a speed bump.

[You]: We missed the ferry because there was an accident on the freeway. We'll get there right in the morning.

[117]: Okay.

Just *okay*.

Katsuki decided he didn't like the Vipers very much.

He exhaled hard as the weight of this whole screwed-up plan pressed down on him. The cracks in his resolve were spreading fast, and he didn't know how much longer he could keep up the charade. His strength had limits, and he was reaching them. He was hoping to get the exchange over with today—before he imploded.

Out of the corner of his eye, he looked at the man responsible for his turmoil—and regretted it instantly.

Izuku's hair moved with the breeze, soft and wild. It caught the faint glow of the moon, showing like a halo around his head. His face was lit just enough to remind Katsuki of every night he'd spent memorizing it in the dark. And for a breath, Izuku seemed so gentle it hurt.

He didn't look like someone who killed the last of Katsuki's family.

But he did.

And Katsuki was here, stuck with him.

He turned away, hands clenched as he shoved the burner back in his pocket.

☽ ☽ ☽

They ended up deciding on spending the night in a water tower.

Izuku was skittish of the Yakuza or Vipers catching up to them, but Katsuki knew this wouldn't be an issue. If Shigaraki was holding up to his half of the deal then neither of those groups were looking for them. But to give Izuku a sense of security, he followed along.

Once they got inside, the tower wasn't what Katsuki expected.

The air was cool, carrying the smell of old water and rust. But it was the color that caught him off guard.

Blue light shimmered all around like it was made of magic.

A high level of water filled the base of the tower. Its surface was glowing faintly from the dull underwater lights embedded along the bottom. The glow made the whole place glitter with a quiet, artificial whimsicalness.

Suspended above it all was a grated metal floor, wide and solid beneath their feet. Off to the side there was a narrow control station. The door they walked through led directly onto the platform, and above them, a spiral staircase wound up to a second level.

Katsuki almost dryly laughed. The color matched exactly how he was feeling on the inside.

Tiredly, he bent to his knees without a word. His body was heavy with exhaustion from carrying his broken heart for too long. In one smooth motion, he shrugged off his pack and jacket, the fabric slapped against the metal floor with a thud that echoed.

He pulled out his sleeping bag and shook off the twigs and dirt that clung to it from the overlook near Izuku's mansion.

Beside him, Izuku kneeled too. He wasn't quite close enough for them to touch, but near enough that Katsuki could hear the quiet movements of him rifling through his duffle bag.

Izuku began to organize the contents. He stacked clothes on top of the hard items, rearranging the bag into something that resembled a makeshift pillow.

With a slight huff, Katsuki laid out the sleeping bag all the way.

He looked once at Izuku and regretted it immediately. His heart skipped a beat. Nope. Too dangerous. He sure as hell wasn't sleeping next to that man. After last night, he couldn't predict what would happen.

He stood up, turned his back, and walked away.

“I’m going to go sit outside,” Katsuki muttered. “Don’t wait up.”

He left out before Izuku could respond.

☽ ☽ ☽

He found himself circling the outer ledge of the water tower.

His boots scraped the metal as he wandered without aim. Once, twice, and then a third time.

The irony didn’t miss him. He’d always been stuck in some kind of loop, hadn’t he? Always spinning in place, chasing warmth that never stayed in his life too long.

He’d been stuck in the same cycle ever since his mother abandoned him in the cold, back turned and no hint of when she would return. Ever since then, he’d been clawing towards what he thought was love, or family, or even a home.

But every time he got close—it vanished because he wasn’t good enough.

Eighteen years of chasing warmth, and all he had to show for it was heartbreak.

The early winter wind picked up, sharp and sudden. It bit through his hoodie and shirt with ease, reminding him too late that he’d left his coat in the tower. He sighed, irritated but not surprised. He thought about going back in to grab it—but stopped himself.

The image of Izuku waiting there, watching him with those stupidly big, concerned puppy eyes, made him feel nauseous. So instead, he stayed out in the cold.

He sat down on the ledge, letting his legs swing over the edge. The town spread out below, small and quiet, glowing dim under the clouded night sky. It didn’t look real—more like a model town under glass.

Then his black smart phone buzzed.

He fished it out of his pocket, thumb already prepared to ignore whatever it was. Denki sent their group chat another meme—some stupid gif with sparkles and an exploding kitten or something equally pointless.

But Katsuki barely registered it. His eyes caught something else.

His lock screen was still Izuku.

He folded his lips into a thin, flat line. He studied Izuku’s smiling face again, and the small butterfly on his nose. On cue, his chest tightened and his eyes started to prickle. He didn’t unlock the phone. He just stared.

And for one long, aching minute, he let himself mourn what they never really had.

Katsuki blinked back the burn in his eyes and shoved his phone deep into his pocket where it couldn't hurt him. The cold railing pressed against his forearms, sinking to his skin through the fabric. He leaned his chin against the metal and stared blankly into the night across the water.

He could see the island from here.

His thoughts wandered—but they always circled back to that last month in Biei. The same month he said "I love you" out loud for the first time in his miserable life. And the month someone said it back.

Suddenly, the sound of a throat clearing caught his attention.

Katsuki's shoulders stiffened.

He turned his head enough to cut his eye at the source—and the second he caught that familiar green in his periphery, his heart skipped and plummeted at the same time.

He huffed and pulled his gaze away, planting it firmly on the dark island across the water.

"Kacc—" Izuku stopped himself. Katsuki heard the way Izuku swallowed the nickname down like it was dangerous to say. "Katsuki. You, uh, forgot your jacket. I-It's cold out here. You might get sick."

And there it was. That infuriating level of care.

Izuku was a walking contradiction, and that was the real problem.

One moment he was all soft glances and careful words, gentle in a way that made Katsuki feel seen. Then the next, he was killer cold. He could be whispering 'I love you' against Katsuki's throat like it was gospel. Then somehow those same lips were capable of hiding the most devastating secret pertaining to Katsuki's life.

It was too much whiplash and Katsuki was ready to have that shit out of his life.

He grunted, not saying a word and held his hand out stiffly for the jacket. Izuku passed it over, clumsy, like he didn't know if he had permission to touch him anymore.

Katsuki took the item without looking. He shoved his arms through the sleeves, yanked the zipper all the way up, and buried his hands deep in the pockets like he could trap the storm inside his chest before it came pouring out.

Because it would. If he let himself speak—or look at Izuku too long—it fucking would.

"Are you going to stay out here all night?" Izuku asked, voice small and almost childlike.

"I'm watching the door," Katsuki snapped. It was a lie, but he wanted to be left alone. "You can go back to sleep."

Izuku shifted on his feet awkwardly. "I-I can't sleep."

Katsuki clenched his teeth and tightened his fist.

“Izuku,” he hissed, worried that being around Izuku too long would crack his resolve. “Go back inside.”

He didn’t want to see Izuku. He couldn’t. Right now, his chest was a minefield. One wrong word, one too-soft look, and everything would blow up.

He gazed across the water to the dark island. He was too close now to get caught up in his emotions. His revenge was right there and his happiness was there waiting for him.

But for some reason, Izuku didn’t leave.

Instead, he came closer. His footsteps rattled the metal beneath them and Katsuki clenched his fists in his pockets. Then he heard Izuku kneel. He dropped softly to his knees against the surface—and the warmth of Izuku’s body at his side, barely brushing his, sparked across his body.

And then—a hand reached out and gripped his shoulder.

Katsuki flinched. It was so soft—and it made his heart twist. He tried to jerk away, and keep his eyes on that island to remind himself how damn close he was. He couldn’t blow this. He had waited five goddamn years.

But Izuku’s grip didn’t give up. He gripped him tighter, refusing to let Katsuki go.

“Please talk to me,” Izuku begged. “*Please*. Or look at me.”

Katsuki shook his head. He shifted away from Izuku’s warmth.

“I *can’t* look at you,” Katsuki hissed, but not angrily. His voice was hoarse with so much torment he couldn’t take it anymore. “The reason why I can’t should be *very* fucking clear.”

Izuku shuffled closer again. “I-I know, b-but please. Look at me.”

He grabbed Katsuki’s jacket and tugged.

Suddenly, Izuku began begging.

He pleaded with soft words and touches that were exactly a day too late.

“No. I can’t do it,” Katsuki hissed. Izuku pulled again, and slowly, Katsuki began losing his composure. Exactly like he knew he would if he got too close to this damning man. “No.” A pull. “I said no—” a tug. “*Stop*—”

“*Please*,” Izuku’s voice cracked.

“No. I can’t do it.”

Katsuki shook his head again, more violently this time. He felt that very small thread holding back all his turmoil began to draw taut, threatening to break. Instantly, all the words he wanted to scream came roaring to the surface. He tried to shove them down, but they were barreling forward, pulled out by Izuku's touch.

"I can't," Katsuki whispered. Izuku pulled more, and more words were forced out. "If I do it, then—"

"—Then what?"

"Then it'll all come *out*!" Katsuki yelled.

The sound echoed over the edge of the tower, vanishing into the dark sky. He hunched over, elbows on his thighs and head hanging between his shoulders like the weight of his thoughts finally collapsed him. His hands began to shake and he began to slip again.

"I won't be able to stop it," he hissed, truthfully. "Everything sitting inside of me will come out and I don't want that to happen."

"Let it out," Izuku whispered.

Katsuki shook his head as he thought about how he was so close to his vengeance.

"I don't want it to—"

"—You have to let it *out*," Izuku pushed. He shuffled impossibly closer, bringing with him his warmth. "Please. Just *look at me*. Let it out and look at me. I don't care what happens or what you say. I'll listen and I'll *take* it all because I deserve it. Scream. Yell. Tell me to go to hell—b-but please. Take it out on me."

Katsuki's vision became blurry.

He shook his head, resistant to what Izuku suggested.

But then gently, Izuku began to caress his shoulders.

The touch was so loving and comforting—exactly like the hug last night.

And exactly like last night, all of Katsuki's anger vanished underneath that touch.

His wall of armor began to crack. His tears were pulled forward from a simple touch of those small, loving hands. He didn't even realize how much he began to cry until the teardrops fell and rapidly fell on the back of his hands.

His face crumbled as he began to gradually turn towards Izuku.

When he finally lifted his head and gazed Izuku in the eye, Katsuki broke.

The love in Izuku's eyes was devastating. It was pure, vulnerable and blinding in its depth. His long lashes were wet with unshed tears, and his nose tinged pink from the cold. His

cheeks were flushed with a soft, raw red. And the wind tugged at his curls, carrying strands across his freckled skin.

He looked so beautiful—exactly like he had in Vienna.

And it hurt so much.

The lid came off. All his grief, rage, and unbearable misery poured out of him at once.

"How could you, Izuku?" Katsuki's voice cracked on the last syllable. "H-How could you look me in my eyes for *that long* knowing the truth and not say *anything*? H-How could you find it in yourself to lie after everything we shared together? I-I've been trying to wrap my mind around that *specific* fact—but I *can't*."

Katsuki tried to stop his tears. He clenched his jaw and everything inside of him came apart.

"I keep replaying that last month over and over," Katsuki wept. He shook his head and Izuku stayed quiet. "Then I keep trying to imagine if there was information that was *that* important to you, could I be able to keep it from you for that damn long? How could you fucking kiss me, have sex with me, and say *I love you* while knowing you were the one who killed her? How c-could you do all that? W-We talked about our deepest fucking insecurities and *everything*—"

He kept going. And as he did, it all compiled.

All his heartbreak, agony, and grief ripped out of him like they were blades trying to escape his chest. They cut through him, excruciatingly. Each ripped open a different part of him and with every new opening came words that he'd been holding in for weeks.

"I-I'm sorry," Izuku whispered past his own tears. "I'm so *so* sorry. I know that was wrong of me, I-I shouldn't have deceived you like that."

"A sorry isn't going to make it right, Izuku," Katsuki sobbed.

Because he made his choice, and it was the island lying right ahead of them.

More words were pulled from him, and it was like a gathering storm the more and more he recounted. He became progressively pissed off as he thought about the red folder, the money, and how he wandered Hadeus worried sick only to find out Izuku had another boyfriend all along. And that same motherfucker was the man who raised a single finger and shattered his world.

The more he thought about it, the deeper the hurt dug in. It was like a storm of knives now, all aimed at Izuku and the sheer fuckery of this ordeal.

Because really—*Chisaki*?

That was the man Izuku chose in the end?

Even if the bastard hadn't been the one to order his mother's death, Katsuki would still slit his throat on general principle alone. He was never good at containing his jealousy. If he found out there were more men Izuku kissed, he was sure he'd kill them too.

"A-And then I woke up alone and *paralyzed* for *hours*!" Katsuki yelled loudly, somewhere in the middle of his rant. "I was trapped in my fucking head for ages, crying out for you! B-But worst of all, you just nonchalantly left that fucking folder there for me to see! Wh-Why would you do that? Why would you think that was the way to tell me the truth, hah?! Why was I not good enough for a decent fucking conversation after I gave my heart to you?!"

"Folder?" Izuku questioned.

Katsuki glared at him through his tears.

"Yes," Katsuki hissed. He leaned into Izuku's face, snarling. "The fucking folder you *left* on the kitchen table where you let me see how much you were *paid* to kill her."

Izuku blinked rapidly and leaned back. "What? I didn't leave a folder—"

"—Yes, you *did*," Katsuki yelled back angrily. "The red folder that was signed and approved by your fucking *boyfriend*. Which is the cherry on top of all of this shit, by the way," Katsuki hissed rapidly as his eyes went wild with hurt.

He kept going, gaining speed on releasing all his repressed emotions.

"Because even after you abandoned me and left that folder I still tried to come and find you to talk to! I-I spent a *week* nonstop searching around Tokyo! I even went down in that dangerous ass underground because I was worried sick about you! I had no clue if you were safe because you didn't even bother to leave any contact information!"

Izuku's expression became bewildered, and it irritated Katsuki.

"But imagine my surprise when people knew exactly who you were and told me you were likely with *Chisaki*," Katsuki spat viciously. "The beautiful Viridian Viper and the goddamn Yakuza Heir: a perfect match made in Hadeus. And all these people were *gushing* about your budding romance and—"

"—Wa-Wait," Izuku said loudly over Katsuki.

Katsuki glared but stopped speaking. He waited to hear whatever useless excuse Izuku was going to say.

"Katsuki—I explained the situation about Chisaki in my letter," Izuku whispered, clearly hurt. "There is no budding romance, wh-why would you ever believe that? I told you Chisaki bought my virginity against my will and my brother was forcing me to sleep with him."

Katsuki's raging train of thought came to a screeching halt.

…What?

He stopped.

Word by word, Katsuki picked apart what Izuku just said. Then once more. Letter. Virginity. Bought? He tried to fit those words in the mess they'd created but they belonged nowhere.

An eerie, unsure sensation began to tap at the back of his neck.

"What letter?" Katsuki asked uneasily.

Izuku blinked.

"The letter I put in your hands after I left," Izuku explained like it was obvious. "It was in a white envelope. I signed it with your name on it and everything."

There was a long stretch of silence as the wind cut through them.

Katsuki's anger slowly but surely was replaced with confusion. He leaned back and stared at Izuku with increasing perplexity as the ominous sensation tapped him harder.

"What are you talking about?" Katsuki questioned. "There was no letter. You left the red folder. Not a letter. And it wasn't in my hands, it was in the kitchen."

"No. I didn't," Izuku shot back, eyes flashing. He looked at Katsuki sideways. "I left a *ten page* letter, explaining *everything* including the truth about your mother. I put it right between your fingers so when you woke up you would have it. I-I even put my cell phone number inside so you could call me if you wanted to."

Katsuki's mouth fell open, but nothing came out.

His eyes slid to the side, scanning his memory but it was a mess like rubble after an explosion. Still, he searched every nook and cranny but found no semblance of a letter.

"…Izuku," he said, voice barely above a whisper. "I didn't get a letter. There was nothing in my hands when I woke up."

"But I put it in your fingers right before I left," Izuku said, voice cracking. Desperation flooded his face as his eyes went wide. "A-And I never had access to archived folders. I had only seen your mother's folder *once*. It was never in my possession. I couldn't have left it."

"Then who did?"

They froze.

Simultaneously, they searched the other for the slightest flicker of a lie.

But there was none.

That ominous feeling completely grabbed him now. No where in Izuku's face was an ounce of deception, which meant Izuku in fact left his number, an explanation and more.

Suddenly, a spotlight cut through the dark and illuminated the vast rift between them. It was a chasm as wide as the sea, filled with missed connections and broken threads. If they were both telling the truth, then something happened in the space between them.

“I think…I think I know who did it,” Izuku whispered angrily. His eyes flickered around, looking as if all the missing pieces floating between were actually there. “My sister, Himiko. She must’ve switched them.”

Katsuki frowned deeply.

Who the fuck was that?

“Hold on.” Katsuki’s eyes narrowed. The newfound confusion entirely overshadowed every other emotion. “How many siblings do you have *exactly*? And why would she do something like that?”

“I technically have about two hundred other siblings,” Izuku whispered.

Katsuki’s eyes startled wide and he blinked rapidly. Two *hundred*?

“And she did it because she hates me,” Izuku explained in an angry but understanding way. “She wants to see me suffer for killing someone she cared about in our cohort. Our upbringing…it punishes compassion and empathy. The only thing she’s ever known is pain and negative emotions. As a result, she’s been holding on to resentment against me all her life to keep her going. So, this swap…it makes sense why she did it. She wanted to hurt me—hurt us.”

It took a while for Katsuki to process what Izuku said. He stared, dumbstruck and in shock.

Izuku had left a letter, and someone who he didn’t even know switched it with the red folder to hurt them. Which meant, all this time…this whole time Izuku he—

Katsuki’s throat tightened as the pieces rearranged themselves in a horrifying new order.

“You…You really left me a letter?” Katsuki asked, voice strangled. “A ten paged one?”

“Ye-Yeah,” Izuku whispered.

Izuku met Katsuki’s eyes again, and the unfiltered anguish in both of their hearts amplified.

Katsuki’s breath began coming out in sharp, unsteady pulls.

“Wh-What was in the letter?” Katsuki asked.

“*Everything*,” Izuku sobbed, and his face crumbled. His tears came down and he looked absolutely devastated. “I-I explained everything regarding your mother’s death. I detailed the whole incident. I explained why I needed to go back to Tokyo for the kids. I even wrote about how Chisaki bought my virginity, and I was planning on killing him for you.”

Katsuki’s eyes stretched wider and wider with every piece of the puzzle.

“You’re right about how I couldn’t find a way to tell you,” Izuku confessed. “My brother Tomura had come to the estate when you were away at your retirement party. He revealed the truth to me, and I broke down in a way I hadn’t before. I-I hadn’t known she was your mother, and when I did, I couldn’t believe I played a part in hurting you that much. Then Tomura warned me not to tell you. He told me you would kill me if I did.”

Izuku’s expression twisted with shame. Woe rippled across his face like a fresh wound reopening as he stared down at his scarred, trembling hands.

“A-And Tomura has always had this frightening hold over me—” Izuku’s breath caught. “And because of that, there’s a piece of me that will probably always believe he has my best interest in mind since he’s saved my life so much. S-So when he told me not to say anything…”

Izuku trailed off, sobs swallowing up his words.

“…You didn’t,” Katsuki finished. “You listened to him.”

Izuku nodded, blatantly terrified.

For a moment, Katsuki’s heart didn’t beat at all. Because reality hit him like a freight train—Izuku hadn’t stayed silent because he was cruel or selfish or careless. He hadn’t lied or run out of cowardice. He’d been threatened by the person who severely abused him all his life.

As Izuku wept, Katsuki’s heart ached for him.

He saw how the years of abuse carved terror so deeply into Izuku’s bones that even now, he was still bleeding from wounds no one else could see.

“Th-That’s why I wrote the letter,” Izuku whispered. “I-I figured if I couldn’t say it out loud, I could try to in words. I-I read in a lot of books how characters gave each other these long romantic letters when words were too hard to say. And I thought it would be the next best option since I didn’t know what to do. I knew you deserved closure, but a large part of me was still underneath Tomura’s thumb. So, I mimicked what I saw in my favorite book to h-help me. L-Like I always do.”

Izuku lifted his gaze.

“B-But I know now, I should have spoken up and told you,” he said sincerely. “I shouldn’t have pretended because if I had just—If I just gave you the same honesty back, none of this would have happened. Himiko wouldn’t have been able to swap the letter out and you wouldn’t have been hurt the way you are now.”

He could picture it perfectly.

Izuku in the dead of night, hunched over the kitchen table. His fingers trembled as he struggled to find the right words. Not because he didn’t care—but because he cared too damn much. He could see the painstaking way Izuku took his time. How he was too scared to say

the truth aloud but brave enough to write it in ink. He likely crossed out sentences and re-wrote them, muttering obsessively. He probably cried so much but finished it anyway.

And then—Katsuki saw himself.

He could imagine a parallel universe where he woke up with the letter between his fingers.

He probably would sit on the side of the bed, clutching it in his hands. His chest would be heaving and his heart would be clawing its way up his throat. He would hunch forward with wide eyes and tears would slip down his cheeks as he read every word. He would have cursed and cried. Maybe even punched a hole in the wall.

But in the end he would've called. He would've called so fast.

And then he would've gone and found his dumbass husband and embraced him.

Tears clouded his vision. Katsuki's eyes danced across Izuku's face, drinking him in. This beautiful, broken man never meant to hurt him. His heart began to ache, but it wasn't for himself anymore. It ached for Izuku.

Izuku hunched into himself, and Katsuki could see little Izuku, doing the same gesture. Small Izuku with the little yellow watch, hunching into himself scared of going home—

—Shit.

Home.

Katsuki's stomach dropped violently as he cut his eyes to the island.

He looked back to Izuku and the wind sharpened.

Panic pressed hard against his spine, snapping him straight. He moved without thinking, closing the distance between them until their bodies touched, until he could feel Izuku's breath trembling against his chin.

Katsuki swung his feet up and turned towards Izuku, fully facing him on his hunches.

Then Katsuki reached his hands out to cup Izuku's darling face.

The way Izuku responded to the touch was like he'd finally come home. His husband dropped his head without sound and curled into him. Izuku's trembling fingers wrapped around Katsuki's wrists as he leaned into the touch.

Izuku looked exhausted. Like he'd been running his whole life and solemnly realized he didn't have the strength to keep going.

As Izuku cried silently, Katsuki felt his broken heart throb.

There was so much he didn't know about Izuku. He didn't know how many siblings he had. Or even how he was raised. He only knew what he could see on the outside, and that was

million dollar luxury cars and expensive name brands. But he had a feeling there was more.

He never pushed while they were in Biei out of fear of scaring Izuku away.

But maybe he should've.

Katsuki forced their gazes to meet and slowly Izuku's sobbing eased up.

"Izuku," Katsuki said firmly. "I need you to tell me *everything* you've gone through from start to finish."

He felt Izuku's grip on his wrists tighten. Then he saw hesitation bloom inside of Izuku entirely out of reflex.

Katsuki's heart dropped.

How much violence did Izuku endure for a reaction to be so automatic?

"Izuku, please," Katsuki begged. He drew in closer until he could count every eyelash on Izuku's face. "I need to know everything, leave out no details. I-I need to hear the whole story so I can grasp the full picture of what's going on with you. C-Can you do that for me?"

"O-Okay," Izuku rasped, voice splintering. "I-I can try, for you."

Katsuki nodded frantically. In one motion he quickly stood up and pulled Izuku with him. Immense urgency flooded his bloodstream as he felt eyes crawl across the water—coming from the island.

Katsuki clutched his husband's hand tightly as he led them back inside of the tower.

He took one more glance at the island and shut the door tight.

☽ ☽ ☽

It took hours. Long, excruciating hours where time felt like it moved sideways.

The whole time, Katsuki held Izuku's hands. He was afraid that if he let go for even a second, Izuku might shatter into a thousand fragments and vanish into the wind. And maybe he would have.

Because what Izuku told him wasn't a story. It was a goddamn nightmare.

Every time Izuku faltered, Katsuki didn't speak. He squeezed Izuku's hands and stayed there, anchoring him with the only thing he knew how to offer: unwavering presence. He didn't rush Izuku. Didn't force him.

He only listened.

And Izuku was brave enough to spill it all. From his lips, every last disgusting detail about his life fell. He spoke of his childhood like it was some far-off memory. He was so

dissociated that Katsuki could see the bleakness sweep across his eyes. It was like Izuku wasn't describing himself, but someone else entirely.

With every new event, Katsuki became more infuriated and sickened.

The fucking belts. The Cull. All the deliberate, escalating sadism.

But what hit Katsuki the hardest was when Izuku described the glass box.

"After Tomura decapitated Nine, he left me there," Izuku whispered. "Everyone did. He turned off the lights and left me there by myself for four days without food or water or a way out."

Something horrific dawned on him.

That afternoon when Katsuki found his mother's body, Izuku had been locked in a cage. When he made her funeral plans the next day, Izuku had still been locked in a cage. And when her funeral happened the morning of the fourth day after her death—Izuku still had been there.

Izuku was trapped in that box, alone, in the dark crying out for *Kacchan*.

Katsuki was mortified.

When they came to the end of Izuku's life story, Katsuki couldn't speak.

His heart was roaring in his ears, and his hands—still wrapped around Izuku's—were trembling out of control. His fingers were shaking and he was about to snap. Because somewhere along the way, while listening to the man he loved recount his life like a goddamn eulogy, the anger in Katsuki transformed.

He'd always known hardship. Always known violence.

But what Izuku endured was uglier than he could ever imagine.

"Izuku. Has anything in your life ever been your choice?" Katsuki asked, entirely pained.

Izuku smiled sadly. He looked at Katsuki like he should've known the answer.

"Choosing to love you was," Izuku whispered.

Katsuki's eyes softened.

Without notice, his heart grew lighter.

The hurt in his chest slowly died a little bit. Even if ever so slightly, for the first time in his life, he felt an inch of healing and closure. It stunned him. Because all this time, he thought he needed revenge to lighten the load he was carrying.

But instead, it was love.

Pure, unconditional love relieved him of his sorrow in a way he never imagined. Because all this time he thought he was unlovable. He thought not a single person could ever love him for him. But really, Izuku loved him. Izuku loved him all their lives and through all his different stages.

Tears glossed over Katsuki's eyes.

He was loved so damn fiercely all this time and he didn't even know it.

"What would happen if they caught you now?" Katsuki asked.

"I'm sure my Big Brother Tomura would force me to marry Chisaki somehow," Izuku answered. "He's probably with Chisaki now, convincing him I'm still worth owning."

Katsuki paused and frowned.

He tilted his head slowly. He opened his mouth, closed it, and wearily slid his eyes to the side.

"What do you mean he's *with* Chisaki?" Katsuki asked carefully. "I thought you said you killed him."

"Huh?" Izuku tilted his head. "When did I say that?"

"Back at the motel, you said you killed your older brother."

"Oh, no. Sorry," Izuku quickly apologized. "The nomenclature is all a bit confusing. Jin is who I killed. He was the agent named The Double Headed Viper. Jin is my *older* brother because he was a cohort above me. But my *Big Brother*, the person who oversaw raising me, is Tomura. He's the one who beheaded our original handler, Nine, and took his position."

Sick realization spread across Katsuki's skin. His eyes stretched wide.

"So, your current handler is…your Big Brother?" Katsuki clarified. "The one who has been hurting you your whole life is *also* your handler?"

His heart kicked up so high he could feel the pulse thudding in his throat.

"Yes." Izuku hunched a bit. "I, uh, never realized that could be mixed up. The relationships inside of the Vipers are a little muddled I guess from the outside perspective. Bigs are in charge of a kid from the cohort below them, and they're called Littles. So, Tomura was my Big and I was his Little. He raised me since I was two and he was seven."

Katsuki forgot how to breathe.

"That's…so young," is all he managed to say between sharp breaths.

"It was," Izuku agreed. "B-But, yeah. Tomura has always controlled everything in my life—and I'm pretty sure the second he gets his hands on me he's going to punish me. And then

he's going to send me off with Chisaki in order to appease him so he can get his merge. He needs me to complete his plans."

Everything snapped into place.

He heard Shigaraki's statement from earlier say, "I do need Chisaki alive to grant me power for a merger I am working on."

The merger was a fucking forced marriage between Izuku and Chisaki.

He took a sharp, horrified inhale when it all came crashing down. The new information perfectly aligned with what Shigaraki—or Tomura, whatever the fuck his name was—said. But this time it painted a much more sordid picture of what his plans really were.

Izuku was Tomura's 'most valuable asset' because he was going to give Izuku to Chisaki. Without Izuku, there could be no merger. Of course Izuku wouldn't work assignments if he was married into the Chisaki family. He would become Chisaki Kai's fucking *spouse*.

Tomura so expertly manipulated the truth, carefully cherry picking information so Katsuki wouldn't be able to detect his real intentions.

Dread washed over Katsuki as he felt the weight of the burner phone in his pocket.

"I-Izuku," Katsuki gasped out, terrified by what he'd almost done. "I'm so fucking sorry."

"I'm sorry too," Izuku whispered, ignorant to what Katsuki was actually apologizing for.

They studied the other.

All the strenuous, unfiltered emotions they were feeling poured out.

"I-I'm so sorry for everything, Kacchan," Izuku wept. "I-I'm sorry I didn't say anything about your mom. I should have. She was so important to you, and I knew that. All this mess is my fault because I couldn't see past how Tomura doesn't always actually know what's best for me—or even *want* what's best for me."

Izuku cried and Katsuki cried too. Izuku gripped tightly onto Katsuki and hung his head.

"I-It took losing you for me to really understand that a-and I'm so sorry about your mom," Izuku apologized from the bottom of his being. "I-I wish I hadn't taken the shot—I-I wish I didn't do it, but I *did*. I did and now I hurt you. A-And I take full responsibility for my part in it. I understand if you could never see me the same—and I don't blame you if y-you don't want to speak again after th-this."

Katsuki screwed his eyes shut and turned his head away.

Grief for his mother tangled with grief for Izuku, knotting inside him until it dragged him under a new, crushing sadness. Neither of them spoke; they just let the tears fall. One after another, splashing into the water below and rippling together like shared scars.

When the silence stretched long enough to steady his breath, Katsuki raised his head.

The only thing he felt—the only thing that mattered—was the pull toward Izuku.

He leaned in and caught him in a desperate embrace, arms locking around Izuku's trembling frame. Izuku clung back as fiercely, as though the world might vanish if he let go. They melted together. Grief folded into grief. Love into love. And Katsuki knew in that instant he would never let him go again.

Not now. Not tomorrow. Not in a million years.

"I'm so sorry, Kacchan," Izuku apologized again, much more unraveled. "I wish I could take it back. I-I want to take it back. I should have let Tomura cut my neck that day. If I'd known she was your *mom*—"

"—It's okay," Katsuki hushed him. He tenderly stroked Izuku's head and rocked him. "I-It's okay, Izuku. You didn't know."

"B-But I think I might've," Izuku replied, voice cracking. "I thought I saw a resemblance between you and her back then. I told myself I was seeing things, a-and—" Izuku cried harder, clinging to him more desperately. "—I'm just so sorry I hurt you so much. I never wanted to hurt you, I only want you to be happy, Kacchan."

Katsuki was too shocked by everything to speak.

Instead, he hugged Izuku tighter. Izuku buried his face in his neck.

They wept softly in the pale blue light, and they didn't let each other go. Katsuki's arms locked around Izuku more and his hand threaded through thick curly hair. Katsuki felt their hearts press together as they both silently cried in the pale blue light.

Izuku kept going, offering up more and more apologies.

He apologized for everything. For things he didn't know. For things he couldn't change. For everything that was out of his control. All the love and regret fell from Izuku's lips directly into Katsuki's hands.

At some point, Izuku wrapped his arms around his neck. He clung to Katsuki like a lifeline, as if he was the only thing keeping him from sinking completely. Izuku trembled with every breath, fully swept away by the storm of emotions he'd locked away for years.

Carefully, Katsuki guided them down to rest.

Izuku struggled to let go, so Katsuki didn't make him. He took off Izuku's shoes for him. Then his own. One arm never left Izuku's back. He kept it wrapped there, protective.

He shifted them over, gliding them delicately. They joined together in the small sleeping bag, fitting together like two perfectly broken glass shards. They laid their heads down together on the duffle bag, facing each other.

Izuku didn't stop apologizing.

He said sorry over and over again like if he said it enough, he could take back all the damage done.

Katsuki stayed silent. He softly stroked Izuku's hair with his shaking hand.

As he cradled Izuku, dozens, if not hundreds, of facts were being processed in his head. They darted around, connecting and drawing the bigger picture. He aligned his and Izuku's life next to each other like two pages of different story books. He read line for line how their interconnected lives fell apart in tandem like two twin stars destined to cross paths in the dark sky.

Eventually, Izuku's apologies trailed off into shallow sobs.

When they quieted, Katsuki shifted again. He guided Izuku onto his back and leaned over him.

Izuku had cried himself to sleep. His cheeks were wet. His eyes were swollen. Redness swept across his ears, cheeks and nose.

The sight tugged at Katsuki. Then one of his own tears fell down onto Izuku's freckled cheek at that moment. It slid away, escaping through one of the holes in the grated floor. It fell into the body of water below them and ripples drifted out.

Katsuki lifted a hand to tenderly dry Izuku's face. His expression crumbled, then it hardened. His chest burned with anger, born anew like a phoenix reignited.

He thought back on his vows and realized how true they were. Katsuki meant them, even more now. Every single damn word.

He would kill for Izuku. He would *die* for him.

But most of all—he would never let anyone hurt Izuku again.

☽ ☽ ☽

It took a long time for sleep to come and get him.

Katsuki laid awake for what felt like hours, staring up at the curved metal ceiling of the water tower.

His eyes remained wide and unfocused. His mind reeled, turning over every grotesque detail Izuku spilled in that shaking voice. Nothing—absolutely *nothing*—could've prepared him for the horrors he'd heard. The truth of the Viper Academy was worse than anything he'd imagined.

But now that he knew, it clung to him like poison in his lungs.

And when sleep finally crept in, slow and reluctant, it found him still awake—wrapped around Izuku in a fierce, protective hold. He held him close, as if shielding him from memories Katsuki couldn't fight.

He began falling into a dream memory again. But this time, it was short.

He landed softly in a thin blanket of snow outside of his old school during winter. He was thirteen, waiting to be picked up. His mother said she would come, and she'd been doing so for a while. So he gave her grace.

He waited. Then waited some more.

Eventually, there was no one left but him. Only Katsuki and the hollow sound of the wind threading through the chain-link fence behind the school.

He glanced down at his shoes and grew unhappy. There were holes in the bottom of the soles. He poorly tried to cover them with duct tape. But the adhesive didn't last the full day, and some wetness soaked through to his sock.

He didn't want to walk home in the snow like this, but it seemed like he was going to have to. Still, stubborn hope clung to his ribs. He gave her more time. More room to prove she hadn't forgotten him.

He waited until the sky shifted from bruised pink to empty black.

And in the silence, his thoughts drifted far away to that boy from Tokyo. The one with the soft green eyes and gentle hands.

Katsuki hoped he was warm and safe.

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki was woken up abruptly by the sound of a ringtone.

He jolted awake, and so did Izuku. They shifted in the sleeping bag with tiredness heavy on their puffy eyes. As they roused, Katsuki's arms were still wrapped around Izuku. He grumbled unhappily as he fished out the ringing phone from his pockets.

Then he stiffened when he realized it was the burner phone ringing.

Katsuki pulled out the phone and frowned. There he could see the flashing number 117.

He sat upright and clutched the phone before Izuku could see.

"Sorry," he quickly muttered as he eased out the sleeping bag. Izuku looked up at him confused. It made Katsuki's heart tug at how red Izuku's nose still was. "I'll…I'll be right back, okay?"

Izuku nodded sleepily and rubbed his eye. "Okay."

Katsuki grabbed his coat and walked out of the tower. The cold winter wind greeted him like an old friend and Katsuki noticed the stark drop in temperature from last night.

His hand shook as he glared down at the phone.

The number 117 continued to blink on the small screen.

Katsuki could've slapped himself right then and there. He almost handed Izuku back over to his brother—his fucking *abuser*. He became truly, deeply nauseous. He realized where he was led astray. It was his damn need for vengeance. His clouded thirst for revenge led him right into being fooled.

Aizawa was right all along.

It was here that Katsuki began to really comprehend why Izuku believed in fate so much.

He always assumed fate was a weak person's philosophy to help them cope with the ugliness of the world. It was an easy way out and a simple excuse for lack of proactiveness.

But now he knew he was wrong.

Fate was real because fate was cruel. It was a vice grip around his throat, sinking claws into his jugular. The more he ignored his destiny, the more pressure fate applied.

Now, after walking down this path for so long, Katsuki was pushed into making the ultimate decision.

He had to choose: Izuku or his revenge. Protect the love of his life or kill Chisaki. Fate forced his hand to finally face the ultimate decision. Because there was no world in which he could have both. But Fate knew what choice he was going to make. It was so acutely clear.

He chose Izuku.

Katsuki flipped open the phone and answered with one swift, concise sentence.

"Deal's off," Katsuki hissed, voice low and deadly. "You're not getting him back, *Tomura*."

He spat the name like it curdled in his mouth.

Silence answered him. A thick, dangerous quiet stretched on like the breath being held before a guillotine dropped.

"…Are you sure this is the path you want to go?" Tomura's voice came through the receiver, smooth and sinister. "You won't get another easy chance to kill Chisaki. Not like this."

Katsuki's fingers clenched around the phone until the plastic groaned beneath his grip.

"You listen to me, and you listen goddamn close," he said, each word ground out like teeth snapping through glass. "I've been fantasizing about killing *you* since I was seven."

His voice dropped to a vicious octave.

“You will never—I mean *never*—get within breathing distance of him again. As long as I’m still walking this earth, I will make it my sole purpose to keep you so far from him you’ll forget what his voice sounds like. You’ll be a footnote in a history that I’m going to help him *burn*. Nothing but a goddamn extra in the background of his life.”

The silence on the other end stretched intensely. He could feel Tomura’s anger rising but Katsuki didn’t wait for the comeback.

“Rot in hell,” he hissed, and tore the phone from his ear.

He snapped the flip phone in half with a satisfying crack. He tossed the broken pieces over the railing and watched them scatter like bones across the dead grass below.

Katsuki’s chest was heaving now, struggling to breathe. His nostrils were flared and tears were pushing at his eyes.

Aizawa was really right.

Revenge wasn’t the path he should have ever been on.

But letting go of his need for revenge was like sawing off a limb. However, Katsuki did it because it was decaying flesh that was spreading its disease through his body. It was turning him into someone he never wanted to be: someone who would hurt Izuku—exactly like Tomura.

He finally admitted to himself that he wanted to protect Izuku more than anything. Even more than revenge. He couldn’t ignore it anymore.

Every time he looked at Izuku, he saw the small boy with the eyepatch. He saw the bloodied wounds and bruises Izuku would always arrive with. He still could feel the broken bones.

It was painstakingly obvious Izuku was still that little boy. And Katsuki still sometimes felt like that same kid stuck in the cold waiting for his mother. But this time, he decided they would break their cycle.

Katsuki needed to learn to let go of his mother in order to save him and Izuku once and for all.

He could no longer be that boy waiting in the cold.

Chapter End Notes

Something I love about this particular story is finally toppling all the long string of metaphors and scenes that have been set up. I think this chapter for me hits well because

Katsuki admits it was love at first sight. I've been waiting to say that for 600k+ words lol.

The full Vienna encounter is at the end of Chapter 19 if anyone wants to re-read that interaction with the new information of Katsuki fell in love there :') it hits differently IMO. I've been waiting for that info because I think it'll make re-reading Part I of this story more sweet when you realize how much Katsuki has been denying being in love with Izuku despite always have been this whole time.

I also think re-reading the scene with Izuku and Katsuki's first truce in the middle of Chapter 20 hits different too with the knowledge :') poor Katsuki has been hopelessly in love just as much as Izuku.

Let me know what you think below!! <3 The next chapter is the very last catch up of Katsuki's POV then chapter 41 we're lapping back into the present ❤️

Chapter 40: Appassionato

Chapter Summary

> Appassionato — (Instrumental indication) to play with a passionate or emotionally intense quality

Chapter Notes

> Helloooo!! :') Another Katsuki POV chapter!! This one is really sweet to me because its such a pivotal moment for his resolve and emotions that have been building up. I love romance ❤️💕
>
> Big thank you to the LOML Luna for Betaing like always! 💜💜💜
>
> :)) Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 40 — Appassionato

.

.

.

Katsuki never felt panic like this before.

He was usually calm on the inside despite his explosive, abrasive personality.

He was loud, but it was in a way that wasn't out of heightened emotions. He just liked getting on people's nerves and never once had to learn to control his tone. But right now, all he could feel was the dull claws of panic burrowing through his chest.

He didn't know what to do—and it made him want to yell into the abyss. *Loudly*.

He'd really screwed up more than he ever fucking had. But worse, he didn't know how exactly to tell Izuku.

Because how did he start that off? He couldn't exactly come out and say 'hey, so while in a fit of hurt, anger and betrayal, I made a temporary deal with your satan spawn of a brother.

The one who beat you non-stop for hours? Yeah that one. I was going to return you to him.'

He was never good with words, that was Izuku's strength. Katsuki was all brute force and action.

Which is why he did the only thing he could think of when his back was against the wall.

He called Aizawa.

Katsuki paced back and forth as the dial tone rang.

Once. Twice. Thrice.

The phone kept ringing, each chime gnawing deeper into his nerves.

Then came the monotone click. A cold, familiar sound that meant no one was going to answer.

Why the hell did this man never answer his phone?!

"You've reached Aizawa," the recorded voice memo said flatly. "I've been forcibly exiled to the Bahamas by The Company due to high blood pressure and an apparent inability to 'decompress.' Their words, not mine. I'm not taking jobs, intel, updates, or emotional crises right now. My phone is off except for this message. If you're bleeding out—try not to."

In the background, Katsuki could hear a distant shout, "Shouta, get in the water!"

"…Alright that's my cue. Leave a message. I won't hear it."

Beep.

Katsuki made a sound that was somewhere between a sigh and a groan.

"I know you're too much of a workaholic to not check your phone," Katsuki said angrily. He paced faster back and forth. "When you do, call me back immediately. It's an emergency. Like a really really *really* big emergency involving the Yakuza."

Katsuki wearily glanced at the island across the water.

"….Please," he desperately added.

It was now staggeringly clear why Izuku struggled to come clean about killing his mother.

Hurting someone he loved—further than he already had—felt impossible. It was like twisting a knife into the wound he was trying to tend to. Practically ripping it open right after watching the one he loved finish stitching it closed.

And after everything Izuku had told him, Katsuki didn't want to cause any more pain.

Which is why when he got back into the water tower, he panicked.

“There’s been a change of plans,” Katsuki blurted out. “Something happened on the island with the safe house, it’s been compromised.”

Izuku sat upright, clearly confused and dazed.

“Compromised?” Izuku question. “As in, something bad happened?”

“Yup,” Katsuki emphasized. “We need to get out of here as soon as possible. I tried calling my ex-supervisor directly to see if there was somewhere else we could go—” Katsuki winced and shook his head, angry with himself. “—But that bastard is not answering his phone right now. Like always.”

A half lie.

But they needed to get the fuck out of here quickly before that bastard Tomura crossed the water. There really was no time to explain. Katsuki hastily figured he could come clean later, when they had more space to discuss it.

They quickly packed their bags and made a list of all the cities they should avoid. Then they decided where they could go in the meantime until Aizawa returned his call.

“We should go back north,” Izuku quickly suggested in the middle of zipping his duffle. “We can head to that Midnight Sento location that Nana gave me. It’s the bathhouse I was telling you about.”

And that was it.

Katsuki didn’t waste any more time. Izuku told him Midnight Sento was located in Shinonsen and he set his GPS for it right away. They hurried out of the tower and onto his motorcycle. Its engine screamed loudly beneath them as he sped down the road.

Not once did he dare to look back at that island.

Because all that mattered now was getting Izuku as far from danger as possible.

☽ ☽ ☽

They made it to the next town quicker than expected. But in Katsuki’s opinion, it wasn’t fast enough. He wanted to keep going, but unfortunately gas wasn’t infinite and neither was their hunger.

They ended up refueling and stopping at a small diner off the road.

Automatically, Katsuki scoped the place out the second they walked in.

He clocked all six exits and memorized any faces that eyed them too long. Overall, nothing raised a flag, but he still didn’t relax all the way. He stayed closely behind Izuku, keeping a hand hovering slightly over the small of his back out of instinct.

He led the smaller man towards a blue booth tucked into the far corner, close to the back door.

Izuku slid in the booth, looking a little more tired than he had that morning. Katsuki didn't say anything as he slid in right next to him, keeping his sharp eyes on the door. When he didn't see anything suspicious, he relaxed only slightly.

He just sat back, crossed his legs, and slung one arm across the top of the booth behind Izuku. He let his eyes scan the windows with mechanical precision.

He only stopped when he felt Izuku's eyes on him.

He turned, expecting a question about the 'safe house' shit. Instead, he found Izuku gawking, perplexed.

Katsuki raised a brow.

"Why are you looking at me like that?" he asked, deadpan.

Izuku shifted in place, suddenly shy. A faint blush swept across his cheeks.

"Uh, you're sitting on the same side of the booth," he said. "Usually, you sit across the table."

"Ah."

Katsuki tilted his head, gaze locking onto Izuku's. He leaned in just slightly enough to make Izuku blush deeper.

"It's safer this way," Katsuki explained seriously. "If someone tries to come at you, I can protect you easier. I usually use this kind of positioning when I'm doing a bodyguard job."

Izuku blinked. His puzzled expression turned affectionate and the tension fell from his shoulders. Then came that smile. It was gentle, bashful and just a little teasing. It was the same one that always riled Katsuki up.

"Does this mean I'm officially your client?" Izuku asked cheekily.

Katsuki's mouth curled into a crooked grin.

"I guess so, huh?" Katsuki replied. Suddenly, he was very appreciative that Aizawa forced him to work green folder jobs all his life. "Who would have thought? After years of being pissy about being put on bodyguard assignments, it came in handy in the end."

Izuku beamed at him, beautifully.

The brightness caught Katsuki off guard. His heart skipped several beats, pulled in by how handsome Izuku was when he smiled. He stared, captivated by the two cute dimples on either side of Izuku's face. He hadn't seen them since Biei—and it made his heart flutter.

He was unaware how his eyes softened.

Suddenly, that damning gravity he always felt around Izuku sucked him in. They sat in silence, eyes locked, each searching the other without a single word.

Katsuki's gaze slowly dropped. It lingered first to Izuku's lips then to the pretty bruises along his jaw. The hickies were lingering proof of their marathon of intimacy from two nights ago. Katsuki really liked the way Izuku wore his mark.

At the same time, Izuku's eyes roamed his face too. The fondness in their eyes tangled together until it became impossible to tell where one ended and the other began.

Then suddenly Katsuki heard a phone ring.

It was faint beneath the low diner murmur and the clatter of plates. Izuku probably didn't hear it. Any other time, Katsuki would have missed it as well. However, it jerked him back to reality because it was the *same* default ringtone the burner phone had.

And holy *hell*. It was like a bucket of ice water was poured over his head.

Katsuki's smile was wiped clean off his face.

He awkwardly cleaned his throat. Regret wrapped its skinny fingers around his throat, strangling him. His eyes skirted down to the table and he scratched behind his head as he tried to think.

Maybe this was a good time to tell Izuku? When their waiter came he could order extra strawberries to smooth it over. The damn nerd loved strawberries.

But when the shame became too much, Katsuki quietly pulled his arm back from behind Izuku's seat and folded his hands on the table.

He chewed on the inside of his cheek as the guilt doubled.

Guilt for what he'd almost done.

And guilt for loving his mother's murderer, in a way.

Because while he adored Izuku, an undeniable fact hung in the air: Izuku did kill his mom.

Above it all, Katsuki prided himself in being a good son. He always respected his mother. He never turned his back on her. Not even when things got ugly between them. He'd been loyal to her in the way only Katsuki knew how to express himself: fiercely, unapologetically, and with a kind of stubborn devotion that bordered on blind.

But now—

…Now he didn't know where the line was anymore.

Izuku shifted beside him, also clearly unsure.

The quiet weight of disgrace settled over the table like soot in the aftermath of a fire that burned down everything they built together. Izuku turned away, slumping against the booth's edge. His bangs fell forward and obscured his eyes, as if even looking Katsuki's way might make it all worse.

Katsuki looked away too, eyes wandering anywhere else besides their broken relationship.

There were too many things fighting for space inside his head and heart.

His mother. The stupid goddamn deal. And finally, the image of Izuku falling apart in front of him as he told his life story.

Katsuki never knew how to process shit. He wasn't built for nuanced emotions. He was made to protect, to save, and to destroy what hurt the people he cared about. This was all new territory for him and he had not a damn clue how to proceed.

"Are we…okay?" Izuku whispered quietly.

Katsuki didn't reply right away. He steadied himself, preparing to come clean about the deal right then and there. He opened his mouth to confess, but stopped when he glanced at Izuku.

Fuck.

Izuku was trembling, ever so slightly.

Katsuki's heart wrung tightly. The damn man probably didn't even realize it.

The assassin he'd been at odds with for eight years was always strong, fast, and able to stand his ground with minimal effort. But this was clearly not that same person. And how could it be? Izuku was clearly struggling to hold it together after his life had blown up—*less than three days ago*.

No matter how damn demented Izuku's family was—he was obviously affected from having such an abrupt, bloody exit. And after everything, the last thing Katsuki wanted was to be the reason Izuku finally broke.

He decided to wait to come clean. He would do it on a day when Izuku didn't look so close to falling apart.

"I'm…processing things. That's all," Katsuki whispered, backtracking. "But yeah. We will be okay."

And that wasn't a lie.

It was one of the few honest things he'd managed to say to Izuku in the last twenty-four hours. They *would* be okay because Katsuki made himself a promise to start working through his shit instead of letting it decay inside him.

Still, the memories of his mother kept washing up on the shore of his mind.

They came no matter what, fully uninvited but also fully unavoidable.

They arrived in fragments. Some jagged and others soft, like pieces of a wreckage finally drifting up from deep water. Each memory shimmered with some old version of her: the warm one, the furious one, or the one who had left him alone. Each one carried the weight of who he was. They showed him how she shaped him into someone who loved too hard and protected too violently.

Now, Katsuki stood in the middle of it all.

He was ankle-deep in the tide of memory, trying to assemble the pieces into a shape he could hold. A lesson, maybe. A map for how to move forward—not away from her, but through her. A tool that could guide him through all the complicated love and pain she left behind.

He would try his best to get there. But it was going to take a while.

☽ ☽ ☽

They made it to the small city of Shinonsen smoothly.

The second they entered, Katsuki noticed an odd eeriness.

A cloud of fog was at their feet. It barely moved, like a breath that'd never been exhaled. Jagged mountains rose up around them with peaks sharp enough to pierce the sky. There were also ominous trees lining the road. Some were stripped bare, branches crooked like broken fingers. Others still clung to their fading fall color, leaves halfway between life and death.

Katsuki could feel Izuku stiffen behind him. His arms became tense around his middle. He didn't need to look to know the other man noticed it too—the atmosphere was dense and dead. Like they'd driven straight into a graveyard.

Katsuki slowed down instinctively, engine dropping into a low purr. They rolled through town, quiet as they could be. Around them, people moved with the speed of ghosts. Their bodies were hunched and everyone was dragging their feet wearing hollow expressions. There was no color in the way they dressed. No rhythm in the way they walked.

The silence here wasn't peaceful. It was uncomfortable, like everyone was waiting for the sky to fall and missed the memo that it already did.

At a red light, Katsuki came to a full stop.

He let one foot touch the asphalt, then glanced to the side.

"Who fucking died?" Katsuki muttered. "Everyone looks like their dogs got run over by a car."

"Yeah, it's…odd," Izuku replied, wearily. "Every single person looks depressed."

Katsuki didn't respond.

He was already cataloging escape routes, suspicious looking people, and anything that looked Yakuza or Viper like. But he stopped when he felt the tension rolling off Izuku's body. It was subtle, but Katsuki noticed the way Izuku's arms trembled.

Katsuki's hand dropped to rest on Izuku's knee. It was a small gesture of reassurance.

He could feel Izuku relax under his fingers.

The light turned green.

☽ ☽ ☽

When they found the building for Midnight Sento, it was about everything Katsuki suspected it would be. It was big, roomy, and the roof was pointed with the traditional Japanese architecture. The outside was painted black with highlights of violet all around.

What Katsuki *didn't* suspect was for the bathhouse to be run by a dominatrix.

It was so obvious in the way she strolled in. Her aura was overpowering and in the back Katsuki could see poorly hidden floggers perched on the walls. She smirked at them, put one of her hands on her hips, and spread out the red fan in her other hand with a sharp whip.

Izuku jumped and Katsuki stared, unfazed, as she coyly hid half of her face and winked.

"Ah! New faces. Welcome to Midnight Sento! My name is Kayama Nemuri," she greeted. "What kind of session may I offer you? We're having a special today in the sauna to accommodate for the terrible news. If you're here for my other services, all my slots are booked until next month."

Katsuki raised an eyebrow. Her services were pretty damn popular, he mused.

After an awkward set of introductions, they were able to get settled in. He learned Nemuri was honestly rather cool.

She didn't ask too many questions once they dropped the code phrase 'One For All'. She hopped straight into giving them a tour of the bathroom. She showed them all the different saunas, lounges, and then finally their living quarters.

Which—only ended up being one single bed. But Katsuki didn't care or mind.

However, what he did mind was finding out he was suddenly *employed*.

Nemuri smiled at them and said, "Now, you can get settled in and tomorrow you'll get to work," like it was no big deal.

"Wait, what—work?" Izuku blurted out, beating Katsuki to the punch.

"Oh yes! I forgot to mention: you're both now employed, congrats!" Nemuri belted out. She laughed with her whole chest and lightly poked Izuku's nose with the end of her fan. "This helps me pay for housing, food, and anything else you may need. You start your shifts in the

morning with cleaning the baths, floors, and servicing guests. I'll get you both your uniforms after dinner."

Katsuki resisted groaning out loud.

If they weren't on the run from the goddamn Yakuza, he would've defaulted to shouting. But he kept his displeasure to himself and acted grateful.

So much for retirement.

They continued to get settled in, and soon found themselves at dinner amongst others. Accompanying Nemuri were two blonde women who were cousins, Ryuko and Takeyama. And then one rather large gruff man named Sekijiro.

All of them were wearing depressed expressions. Perfectly matching the other residents in this weird town. But despite that, Katsuki could decipher this bathhouse set up was a don't-ask-don't-tell type of arrangement for people in tough positions.

Then during dinner they learned why everyone was acting so depressed.

"Our mayor's daughter passed away," Nemuri explained sadly.

"Did you all know her well?" Katsuki followed up.

"Yes," Sekijiro answered. "She was like the sun around here because she was this huge socialite. Everyone knew her and she would throw these grand fabulous parties for free and let people come and mingle."

"She was also preparing to be the next mayor," Ryuko added with taut lips. "Everyone was really looking forward to it because she basically knew everyone by name individually. It made sense for her to be the next in line. She finally made this foggy city feel like a community."

Damn, Katsuki thought. No wonder everyone looked like they were in a graveyard. The whole town was collectively grieving.

"That's so sad," Izuku whispered. "I'm sorry for all of your losses."

"Thank you, Izuku," Nemuri replied. She tried her best to smile. But Katsuki could see it wasn't sticking. "I guess everyone is just finding it tough to adjust without her because it happened so suddenly."

"If you don't mind me asking, how did she pass?" Izuku probed carefully.

"It was a car accident," Nemuri answered. "Car crash. The fog here gets so thick sometimes that it is hard to see. It was so heavy the day she was coming back from work, and it caused someone to veer into the opposite lane. They had a head on collision at high-speed leaving three injured, one dead."

Katsuki's eyebrows knitted together.

“That’s horrible,” he muttered. “I’m really sorry you all are experiencing that.”

“At the end of the week her father is hosting an impromptu lantern festival to honor her,” Nemuri said. “It’s something she would’ve liked, to bring everyone in the city together one more time. But she wouldn’t want it to be all about her since her parties never were. Her gatherings were always honoring other people. So, this festival will be in her ways. Everyone attending is allowed to remember the memory of their own loved ones who have passed.”

Izuku stiffened.

So did Katsuki.

Immediately, he thought about his mother. Then sadly, he thought about his father. He could see them both standing there in front of him. Two of the most important people in his life, gone too soon.

Then a memory surfaced. It was one he hadn’t thought of in years.

He’d been six, clutching his mother’s hand as they stood at the edge of a riverbank. There was a lantern flickering in his small palm. It’d been for his father and held the name ‘Masaru’ on it in neat handwriting. It was a ritual his mother insisted on because she was slightly superstitious.

She cried the whole way through. But in the end, she still let the lantern go.

At the time, Katsuki was too young to fully understand the weight of the ritual. But now, standing amid the fragments of his memory, he realized he’d never done the same for her.

Never made a lantern. Never said goodbye. Never even lit a candle.

He wondered if that’s why she constantly haunted his dreams.

Maybe she was begging to be let go.

☽ ☽ ☽

Later that night after they went to bed, as if on cue, Katsuki fell into another dream about his mother.

This time, he was fifteen going on sixteen.

He noticed these dreams were progressively moving backwards, showing him his life in reverse. He searched the memory this time closely, wondering if an answer about how to process his grief was hidden inside.

The edges of the dream were tinged grey, like he was viewing it through fog. This was the year everything hovered in limbo. He’d been working for Aizawa for about a year now. But it was also two years before he was put on M-Unit, making it a rather lonely time.

He’d almost forgotten how cold that kind of loneliness could feel.

In the dream, it was the week before his sixteenth birthday. He hadn't planned anything. Birthdays never meant much after his dad died. Besides, no other birthday would ever come close to that one summer in Tokyo—the one time a green-eyed boy made him feel like he mattered just for existing.

But his mother had other plans this time.

"Let's throw you a huge party!" she declared happily. Her eyes were gleaming and her hands clapped together excitedly. "It's your sixteenth! That's a big fucking deal, brat."

He scoffed quietly. "Who would even come?"

"Invite your classmates and maybe some coworkers," she suggested casually.

He didn't know how to tell her he didn't have any friends at school.

Even though the kids at his new school in Yokohama didn't know him when they were poor, they still didn't like him. It was like they could see the grime Katsuki used to be covered in. Even after the new clothes, the fixed shoes, and the thick silver chain around his neck—he still felt like he didn't fit in.

It was as if he was masquerading as a normal teenager.

And the people at work kept their distance from him. Most of his coworkers didn't like the way he spoke. Something about his personality being too loud and obnoxious. But frankly, Katsuki didn't give a fuck. He was good at being a loner.

But right now, as he looked at his mom, he suddenly minded the fact he didn't have friends.

He distantly thought back to the boy from Tokyo who never celebrated birthdays.

"Clean up and decorate!" she exclaimed, beaming. "I'll handle the cake. This is gonna be awesome!"

And for once, Katsuki believed her. He let himself get swept into it.

He went and splurged on some All-Might style decorations for his birthday. He bought posters, banners, confetti and more. He even bought himself a new outfit, a special deeper shade of black that he thought accentuated his paler features.

When the day finally came, no one showed up.

He invited his whole class, awkwardly. He even tried to invite anyone who seemed about his age at The Company. Which was exactly two people. But not a single person came. And now he was in their apartment surrounded by stupid decorations and party blowers.

He waited. He waited and waited and waited for any goddamn extra to show up.

But no one came.

Not even his own mother.

He'd been sitting waiting for her. The sun went down and now he was in the dark. He didn't have it in him to get up and go flip on the light switch. He stared at the two crooked wax candles on the dirty counter. One candle was a 1 and the other was a 6.

When she finally came home, she was drunk and high. She stumbled through the door with no cake in hand, just an empty bottle swinging from her fingers. She was slurring apologies and crying but Katsuki didn't really care to hear it. He didn't bother getting angry.

This is what he should have expected from her.

He was more angry with himself for being dumb and getting his hopes up. So he didn't yell or slam the door like he might've years before. Instead, he helped her to bed. He ignored the way she stumbled over her words and his heart clutched when he heard the faint whisper of 'Masaru' escape from her lips.

He tucked her in, went back to the kitchen, and tore down every shred of the party he'd tried to create.

He ignored the way his eyes stung as he ripped down the streamers, the banners, and cleaned up the stupid confetti. He stuffed all of it into a trash bag along with his hopes of ever feeling special. He tied it up tight like it'd never happened.

Katsuki set his alarm for 05:00 a.m. He had an assignment in the morning.

Before he left for work the next day, he laid out the usual: water, painkillers and a slice of toast.

Everything she'd need for the hangover.

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki woke up in the middle of the night feeling hollow.

He saw what the dreams were trying to show him plainly now, as if the curtain were pulled back.

So much of his entire life revolved around his mother. Every ounce of joy, sorrow, and every decision he made hinged on her. All the good memories and the sad ones were orbiting around her moods. It was always all about her validation and her pain.

Even now, long after she was gone, he couldn't seem to figure out how to feel joy unless he imagined she'd be proud of him for it. And what kind of life was that? What kind of goddamn existence was it if he couldn't even breathe happiness without her ghost's permission?

He turned his head slightly, eyes adjusting to the low light. He found Izuku asleep peacefully beside him. A calm breath escaped him at the sight.

Izuku was probably the only person who could ever understand his pain. They were the same, really. Two people who spent their entire lives putting others' happiness before their own.

Sadly, his heart pulled towards his mother's murderer.

Izuku's eyes were shut and his face was relaxed in deep sleep. He had the faintest parting of his lips giving way to soft, even breaths. His eyelashes were impossibly thick, especially the bottom ones. They were long and curled like they'd been painted there with care.

Suddenly, all Katsuki wanted was to be closer to the one person who understood him.

He hesitantly lifted his hand and touched Izuku's shoulder.

And like a magnet being drawn home, Izuku stirred. He sighed softly as he leaned into the touch. Katsuki felt his chest tighten when Izuku turned inward, curling closer without hesitation. He sought Katsuki out like it was a reflex born of all the nights they'd held each other in the dark in Biei.

Katsuki never got these dreams then, he realized.

His eyes traced every curve of Izuku's gentle face. And then, Izuku's lashes fluttered open.

Beautiful green eyes stared at Katsuki.

Neither of them spoke.

Katsuki wistfully stared into a sea of deep green. All he wanted was to submerge himself in it.

He moved in closely towards the other man. His arms slipped around Izuku's waist, wrapping him tightly. He held on like Izuku was a lifeline and tangled their limbs. Izuku stared quietly. No words were exchanged as they defaulted back to the way they used to be all those endless nights together.

Katsuki hugged Izuku close, afraid to let go. The ache in his heart slowly dissipated under the act of affection. Following that feeling, Katsuki rested their foreheads together and he closed his eyes. His heart hurt less and less the longer Izuku was safely in his arms.

He let himself take this inch of selfish comfort without guilt.

And when he finally fell asleep again, with the man he loved curled into him, the dreams didn't return.

☽ ☽ ☽

At the end of the week, the lantern festival occurred.

Between failed calls to reach Aizawa, Katsuki contemplated what to do. Should he even participate? They were just passing through.

But as he stared at the crowd of people gathered, he saw how much this meant to the town. In everyone's hands was the name of someone they loved, honoring their memory.

All around them, hundreds of people were gathered holding up lanterns. Every lantern in their hand was cradled delicately, showing how cared for each of the departed was. The surrounding buildings were dimmed. No lights were on, giving space and respect for the fallen souls. Even the fog thickened up a touch, reducing the visibility.

Nemuri led their small group to the front of the festival. There was a large crowd of people gathered, being handed lanterns and matches. Everyone was lighting a flame, and then heading towards the town square.

Katsuki observed as all the employees of the bathhouse grabbed a lantern.

Everyone but Izuku, that is. He noted Izuku stared at the lanterns solemnly but didn't dare move to grab one. Instead he clasped his hands behind his back and put his head down. His expression was tight and it translated one thing: a killer like him shouldn't be amongst mourners.

Katsuki felt the same.

He'd killed mothers. Fathers. He'd even killed politicians and priests. Katsuki had been collecting souls since he was thirteen with little regret up until it affected him.

What a damn hypocrite he was—a killer sad because his mother was killed.

The irony was palatable. But his pain was undeniable.

Katsuki watched as everyone around him wrote their loved one's name on the paper material. He stayed in place, unsure of what to do. Grief pushed its roots in deep, and for a moment, Katsuki hated how familiar this paralysis felt. It was like he was twenty again, clutching the corner of an apartment wall while they zipped her body bag shut.

All the members from the bathhouse were finished and began to move forward without him.

Izuku stepped forward too, but stopped when he felt Katsuki's hesitation. He turned and glanced over his shoulder, and instantly they caught gazes.

"Should I get one?" Katsuki asked, unsure.

He trusted Izuku's opinion; Izuku was always good with shit like this.

"I think you should," Izuku replied gently.

And for some reason, that made it easier. Katsuki drew in a breath and stepped forward. He borrowed from Izuku's mountain of emotional strength as he approached the table. He reached for a lantern and the paper felt delicate for what it was meant to carry.

With an unsteady hand, Katsuki wrote his mother's name.

Bakugou Mitsuki.

Fog pressed in around his ankles, curling at his calves like hands made of smoke.

Katsuki grabbed a match and together they walked into the crowd. They met up with the rest of the group from the bathhouse and all of them marched towards the town square.

When they arrived, there was an older guy with sleek silver hair mounted on a stage. He was in front of a wooden podium. He scanned the hundreds of citizens with a gaze Katsuki recognized. He'd seen that same look in his eye reflected in the mirror often when he was twenty. It was the type of grief that etched its way into someone's heart only when the core of it was wrongfully shot out.

"That's the mayor," Sekijiro whispered to Izuku.

Katsuki heard him too and nodded.

When the tribute started, Katsuki's heart clenched as he gazed around at all the people holding lanterns. He sourly wondered if any of these people were the hundreds of victims he pumped lead into within the last decade.

The mayor gave a heartwarming speech. It was a solid tribute to his daughter who, from the sound of it, was a beacon of light. All the citizens were brought to tears, and it made both Katsuki and Izuku nearly cry as well.

Then the mayor reached for his lantern.

He lit it with steady hands.

And then one by one, the crowd followed.

A thousand flickers bloomed across the square like fireflies shaking off sleep.

Light spread in waves, golden and slow, until the entire space glowed. The fog still hung heavy, but now it filled with warmth like the dead were all here, watching and extending their love. Katsuki looked out over the rows of people, a sea of yellow light breaking through the gray. Each lantern shimmered like a steady heartbeat.

He exhaled, shaky and unsure.

Scarlet eyes dropped to the unlit lantern in his hands. The match felt too small to represent the force his mother always was. Yet, he still struck it. The flame bloomed against the night, and he moved it carefully to the wick. But the winter wind blew in with a whistle and swiftly snuffed it out before the fire could take.

Katsuki stared, caught off guard.

He tried again, flicking his wrist and striking a new flame. But once more, the winter wind that he was all too familiar with came back. It snuffed out the light almost in a mocking way.

He tried a third time, and he couldn't stop his frustration from showing. His fingers trembled as he tried to light the lantern.

But yet again, it was blown out.

That was like the final, tiny tipping point. The tight coil in his throat clenched, and behind his eyes the pressure built. Quickly, this wasn't about the lantern anymore. It was everything. Every single goddamn thing. Why did he always have to fight for scraps of warmth the world handed so freely to everyone else?

Everyone else had their lanterns lit. Everyone else was moving forward.

Why was he *always* the one left behind?

Suddenly, Izuku stepped forward. Without asking, he held his hands out as a shield against the vicious winter winds.

Katsuki's head snapped up, surprised.

A soft, amber glow from the nearby lanterns bathed Izuku's face in warm light. It framed his cheeks and kissed the lashes of his downturned eyes. The glow outlined him like a beautiful painting that possessed exactly the right touch. Izuku smiled at him with a tenderness laced in sorrow, as if he understood without needing to ask.

Of course. It was always Izuku who shielded him from the cold.

All of the love inside of Katsuki burned brighter and his eyes softened.

He lit the lantern this time without issue, with the help of Izuku.

He held his hand out to protect the small wick. Together, they safe guarded the flame for Mitsuki.

It hit Katsuki then he didn't have to carry his grief alone. All his life, he'd been doing it alone. Struggling to manage his emotions without ever speaking about how they torn him apart. But here Izuku was, helping without being asked.

The mayor then stepped down from the podium and held up his lantern.

He walked off stage and led the way with his head held high. He strolled through the thick fog and led all his citizens towards the river. All the various people began following, and soon they stopped where a river passed by the base of a tall mountain. The wide stream spilled right into the dark, vast ocean.

The crowd of people began to split. Groups shuffled along on either side of the long river.

The mayor stepped forward first.

From his spot at the front of the river, he released the lantern holding his daughter's memory. The flow of the water carried her away from him. He watched her leave, and there was

wisdom in the action. He observed with eyes full of love, not mourning, as she was able to continue on without him.

Next, everyone else released their lanterns. Each one joined in the water behind hers.

By the time her lantern made it to where Izuku and Katsuki were, the river was a glowing golden constellation of loved ones. Hundreds of names passed by, and distantly Katsuki could hear gentle laughter, quiet talks, and feel all the hugs and heartfelt confessions. The bright lights shone across his face, mimicking the fondness that was shared between everyone here.

One by one, all the employees from the bathhouse began to let their lanterns go.

Soon everyone around them did the same.

Katsuki watched as person after person placed their lantern down. Everyone released them into the narrow stream. Beautiful yellow lights wove together like a glowing procession of memory that flowed like a living ribbon of warmth through the dark.

It was Katsuki's turn to let go now.

But when he tried, his fingers trembled. His grip tightened instinctively around his mother's lantern.

He looked around at the crowd, and in an instant, he wasn't twenty-five anymore. He was twenty-four. Then twenty-three. Then twenty. Eighteen. Each year peeled away like layers of dead skin, leaving him raw beneath the weight. He was all the versions of himself at once, tangled in the same old ache. Grief was the glue that held them together, every year of his life stitched into the next by the pain that centered around her.

Suddenly, he was seven again, still searching for her face in the crowd.

His fingers couldn't move.

Nemuri then turned to Katsuki quietly when she noticed his hesitation. She placed a kind hand on his shoulder.

"Take your time," she said gently. "We're all going to go back to the bathhouse now. When you're ready, head home. No curfew tonight."

Katsuki nodded stiffly, beyond grateful. Nemuri gave Izuku a knowing glance and Izuku mouthed 'thank you' to her. The bathhouse employees left them there, and soon the crowd began to thin out.

Katsuki held the lantern close to his chest and he was so goddamn thankful Izuku didn't push him.

Katsuki moved first. He took a hesitant step forward along the shore of the river. He began to walk down the edge and Izuku followed him quietly. They walked together in the night air side by side, watching all the lanterns float by at their feet.

When they came down to the end of the river where it spilled into the ocean, they finally stopped.

Katsuki stared out at the endless, dark horizon that was coated in fog. He tightened his fingers around his mother's lantern and looked sadly at the dark horizon in front of him. It was nearly pitch black, and all the lanterns were floating out into it. One by one they were swallowed up by the darkness on the other side of the threshold.

Katsuki's heart hummed low.

"Why did it have to be you?" He whispered. "Out of all people, why you?"

The wind blew, and Izuku hung his head. His eyes skirted off to the side, counting the lanterns that passed them by.

"I don't know," Izuku eventually said. His voice was so low Katsuki could barely hear it. "I wish it wasn't."

"Me too," Katsuki replied quietly.

Katsuki tried to find logic behind their situation.

But there was none, and this all felt too connected to chalk up to some horrible coincidence.

What if it really was fate?

Izuku believed in fate. Maybe Katsuki should stop questioning it so much because right now, it seemed like the only answer to this demented dance they were stuck in. So he began reasoning out loud, because really, what else could he do?

He lowered his head as he squatted down on the patch of grass next to the river. Izuku joined him wordlessly, leaving space between them that no doubt was room for all their hurt.

Katsuki painfully looked at the lantern in his hands. The yellow light illuminated his crestfallen face, making him appear younger than he was. A line of countless lanterns passed them by on the river. One by one they watched them go while the one in Katsuki's hand stayed rooted in place.

Katsuki turned to Izuku.

"But even if it wasn't you, another Viper eventually would've killed her, right?" He whispered.

Izuku's eyes softened under the yellowish light. His eyes darted around, studying Katsuki's face as if he was unsure he should speak. But he did, and what he said gave an inch of closure.

"…Yes." Izuku admitted.

“And if I didn’t kill that guy when I was thirteen, he would’ve killed her. And if I didn’t stop Aizawa, *he* would’ve killed her—and who knows who else.”

He saw all the connections. Every gun raised against his mother, he stopped. She always danced along the line of death, never properly taking care of herself. From here, he aligned his and Izuku’s lives side by side yet again—and what he found was that their situations were inevitable.

No matter what, his mother was destined to die young.

Or rather, maybe she was fated.

She was fated to die.

“Y’know,” Katsuki said bitterly. “I asked her once who would want her killed for owing a debt and she couldn’t even come up with a list. She said it could be *anyone*. Somehow, someone always would have likely killed her because she always had her past chasing her.”

Izuku’s brow pulled together. “What type of past did she have?”

“That’s the thing, I don’t *know*.” Katsuki’s voice cracked. His eyes blurred with tears. “I will never know. That will always be an open ending for me because I realize I-I didn’t know my mom very well. But all I did know was that her gambling addiction put her in so much shit.”

Katsuki clenched his jaw thinking of all the time he came home to people in the house.

“I still blame Chisaki for taking advantage of someone with an addiction,” he hissed. “But I have to blame her a bit too, don’t I? All this time I thought she died because of a mistake *I* made—” Katsuki choked as he sucked in his lips. “When really, she died because it was a mistake she made. All this time, it had nothing to do with me.”

And that was really it, wasn’t it?

It had never been about him. It was always about her.

He should have known that even her death had nothing to do with him. He was always sidelined in their lives.

“She could never stay away from the things that put her in trouble,” Katsuki mournfully admitted. “No matter how much I wanted her to, she was always doomed from the start. And I think even my father knew that. It’s why his dying wish to a *five year old* was to take care of his mother. He knew she wouldn’t have been able to survive on her own—because her worst enemy was herself. B-But I couldn’t save her in the end…no matter how much we both loved each other.”

Katsuki looked down at the lantern in front of him.

The more he gazed at the flickering light, the more he felt the fog around his memories fade. Everything became painfully, crystal clear. He suddenly understood now why he held so

many visceral insecurities. So many violate emotions that he suffocated over and over in hopes they died.

But emotions like that didn't die, they grew stronger until they were given the right fix.

"My love for her was never enough and that always made me feel like *I* was never enough," Katsuki whispered. "I cried, yelled and I screamed at her to be better. But she wasn't capable. All I wanted was for her to live and see how much potential she had. She was the center of my world for so long and when she passed, I had no clue what to do with myself. I had never —"

Katsuki stopped.

Izuku's eyes grew full of pity, and for once, Katsuki didn't feel disgusted.

He felt seen.

"I had never thought of putting myself first," Katsuki admitted. "I sacrificed my grades in school for her. I took that job *for* her. I didn't even have time to go out and make friends outside of work. I did all I could to take care of us—because that was all I ever knew. Just… take care of mom and be a good, grateful son."

Katsuki's face dropped as a revelation dawned on him.

"…And that always kept me away from happiness because I was so preoccupied with centering her. Didn't it?" Katsuki whispered.

The other man didn't answer. Instead, he let his actions talk.

Izuku shifted closer and hugged his arms around Katsuki's shoulders. Warmth shielded him from the cold, and Katsuki leaned his head against Izuku's.

He tried to stop the words, but they kept coming. Izuku's small hands soothed him, rubbing softly at the space between his shoulder blades as gently as possible.

"Y'know, I never had hobbies because I was too worried over her," Katsuki whispered, feeling utterly raw. "I worked too much to enjoy life because I needed to pay for two of everything. Part of the reason I gave up on ever finding a relationship was because I felt like I wouldn't find the time. My whole life was about her—and even now, it somehow still is."

Izuku hugged Katsuki tighter as his own tears began to spill down.

"I know she loved me to the full capacity she was able to, and I loved her too. I always will—but even now in a twisted way, she's *still* blocking me from happiness. My grief over her is keeping me away from you. I think…I think if I ever want real happiness, I need to stop centering her. Don't I?"

"I can't tell you how to live your life, Katsuki," Izuku mournfully murmured. "You have to do what you think is right."

“I know. But the happiest I ever was in my life was with you at the estate,” Katsuki confessed. “It was the first time I wasn’t focusing on her in my *whole* life. I thought it was retirement making me happy, but it was you.”

Katsuki lifted his head and drew back from the embrace. His eyes locked onto Izuku like he was the last anchor tying him to the world.

“I want to be happy, Izuku,” Katsuki confessed. A tear rolled down his cheek as he looked at all the freckles he wanted to kiss. “Do you think I’m capable of it?”

“I do.” Izuku wiped away the tears delicately. “I know you’re capable of it.”

Izuku looked down at Katsuki’s trembling hands.

Without a word, Izuku moved closer.

Gently, he laid his hands over Katsuki’s. The warmth of his palms spread like balm, steadying Katsuki. Katsuki’s calloused fingers, marred from a lifetime of violence, twitched beneath the soft touch. But slowly, his shaking began to still. Their hands fit over the lantern like they were made to meet here, at this exact moment, in this exact way.

Katsuki lifted his gaze to look across the lantern.

And when he caught sight of Izuku, it hit him like an arrow through the center of his chest.

The lantern’s light spilled upward between them, catching the slope of Izuku’s face, illuminating him from beneath. The rich light painted every curve in warm honeyed tones. His lashes cast shadows on his cheeks. The faintest freckle on his jaw caught the glow. He looked celestial. Somehow fragile and infinite all at once.

And in that instant, Katsuki saw the truth with bone deep clarity:

Izuku had been his light this entire time.

Through all the years. Through every bloody sunrise and sleepless night. Through the guilt, the pain, the aching silence of losing everything. Izuku somehow was always there. Constantly steady when Katsuki fell apart. And once more, he stood here with him, shielding his hands from the cold.

Katsuki’s breath hitched.

His chest burned.

He could feel the love inside him rising, unable to be contained.

Izuku looked at him, viridian eyes glowing like twin embers in the dark. His gaze was full to the brim with understanding, translating that he saw Katsuki for all he was and wasn’t afraid.

Their eyes dropped to the lantern. His mother’s name shimmered.

And with fingers still intertwined, they bowed.

Together, they released it.

The lantern slipped from their hands and floated downstream. It remained gentle and glowing like Mitsuki's soul was finally at peace. They stayed kneeling beside one another, watching in silence as it drifted toward the ocean through the fog, joining the rest of the souls on the other side.

☽ ☽ ☽

Later that night when they went to sleep, like expected, Katsuki fell into another dream of her.

But this time instead of sliding backwards, the dream pushed him forwards.

He was nineteen again, cast in the light of a long-forgotten winter.

The apartment was warm, muted, and familiar. He sat on her living room couch with one leg slung over the other, phone in hand, idly scrolling through Tinder profiles. One forgettable face after another until he paused on someone. The guy had dark hair, sharp eyes, and a smirk that sort of mirrored his own.

Just as his thumb hovered over the screen, his mother leaned over and swiped left with a sharp scoff.

"Hey! What the hell?" Katsuki snapped, jerking his head toward her. "I was gonna swipe on him!"

Mitsuki rolled her eyes. "He looked mean."

"So? I'm mean. Maybe it would've worked out."

"You're not mean," she muttered, rolling her eyes. "You're passionate—it's different. You're loud and stubborn and reckless—but mean isn't one of your traits, no matter what you think."

Katsuki was about to rebuttal, but was shut up by the look she gave him.

"You're a lot like me, Katsuki," his mother suddenly lectured. Her tone slipped to the softest he ever heard it as she gazed down sadly at his calloused hands. "People like us—we don't need matches, we need counterweights. Somebody who'll keep us from spinning out. Someone who's water to our fire."

She glanced away for a second. Her voice cracked just slightly.

"Masaru was that for me," she confessed in a whisper. "And even though we only had five years…they were the happiest of my life. I want that for you too, Katsuki. I want someone who'll soften you. Hold you. Love you like you *deserve*."

Then, without asking, she reached for his phone again and swiped to the next profile.

And there he was.

Izuku.

Freckles, deep green eyes, and dimples.

Katsuki blinked. Something shifted in the dream. The couch was the wrong color. The coffee table had swapped sides. And yet, there he was—his Izuku—smiling back at him through the screen.

“Oh, now this one’s cute,” Mitsuki cooed, practically beaming. She leaned in, reading aloud with interest. “Same age as you. He likes books, romantic movies, classical music, walks in the park…” She gasped. “And he volunteers at an animal shelter! Look at that. He’s a goddamn saint.”

Katsuki froze, totally confused as the memory twisted wrong.

“I always wanted you with someone like this,” Mitsuki whispered. “Someone who’d love you for every part of you—especially the parts you don’t like. I think he’d be very good for you.”

She swiped right.

The world tilted with the motion.

Suddenly Katsuki was no longer simply nineteen on her couch—he was in another world entirely. It was a parallel universe where Izuku wasn’t a Viper but rather he was a normal guy in college. Izuku was studying toxicology, volunteering with kittens and had straight A’s. This Izuku wore thin, hexagonal glasses perched on his cute nose while rehearsing violin at the Yokohama Orchestra.

And Katsuki was in love with him.

The dream showed him slices of a life he never had.

It showed him their first date in the park where laughter spilled between them like sunlight. It showed him them cooking dinner side by side in Izuku’s cramped kitchen, stealing kisses between the sizzling of the pan and the boiling of pasta.

Then finally it showed him in his mother’s apartment. Izuku was curled up on the couch while she talked his ear off. He’d gotten her pink carnations, and she was so happy. Katsuki was across the room making dinner, sneaking glances like a love-struck idiot. Izuku chuckled lightly while his mother went on about some work drama.

They caught glances across the room and Katsuki smiled gently at him. Izuku smiled back, eyes soft and full of adoration.

Later, as Izuku prepared to leave, Mitsuki pulled him into a warm hug.

“Come back any time, okay, Izuku?” she said, swaying a little. “I’m so happy you two found each other. You have no idea.”

“Of course, Mrs. Bakugou!” Izuku flushed pink and nodded quickly. He hugged her back. “I’ll bring that apple pie recipe when I see you again.”

Next, Izuku hugged Katsuki tight. They said their goodbyes and Katsuki kissed the top of his head. And just like that—Izuku was gone but his warmth lingered.

Katsuki stood there in the dream, stunned. His heart ached because why did this feel so *real*? The way Izuku’s hand fit in his. The way his mother looked at Izuku. He could see how easily they would’ve loved each other.

Mitsuki’s voice broke the stillness.

“He’s way out of your league, y’know,” she teased, nudging him. “But you two fit. I like him.” She gave him a long, knowing look. “What’s that thing you call him again?”

“…Darling?”

She grinned.

“Yeah. That. Never thought I’d hear something so sappy out of your damn mouth.” She stepped closer and smoothed his hair down like she used to when he was little. Her voice turned wistful. “Now stop being a brat and go be with your darling, Katsuki. I always hoped you’d find someone like that. And it’s a damn miracle someone that sweet can put up with you.”

She laughed and her voice cracked, just slightly.

Then her tone softened. “It’s time to wake up now.”

Katsuki frowned. “Can’t you stay a little longer?”

“No…I can’t stay anymore. My time is up.”

His mom then backed away. Step by step she got closer to the door. Then she turned away, back towards him. She put her hand on the door handle. Instantly, Katsuki saw the memory of her walking away when he was seven. It overlapped with her figure at that moment.

Immediately, he jerked forward, and tried to grab her out of reflex.

“Mom—wait. Don’t leave me again—”

He tried to grab for her, but his fingers fazed right through her.

He frozen when he tried again and found he could grab nothing. She paused with her hand on the handle.

She glanced back over her shoulder with that same sad, stubborn smile.

“I’ll never leave you, Katsuki,” she whispered. “I’ll always be with you.”

She opened the door and a bright light poured out.

Katsuki shielded his eyes and held back tears. When the blinding, overwhelming light softened, Katsuki’s heart stopped. Beyond the threshold, he could see his dad, smiling. Masaru stood there like he’d been waiting for her all these long years.

“Mitsuki,” he called, voice like warm tea. His eyes brightened with love. “What took you so long?”

“Sorry,” she laughed, her voice trembling. “Me and Katsuki had some healing to do first. But we got there. He finally lit a lantern for me.”

Katsuki watched, tears slipping down his face, as his parents reached for each other. Their fingers laced like they’d never let go. And in that final moment, bathed in light, they turned back toward him.

Their faces were radiant with peace for finally being reunited.

“Go be happy, Katsuki,” his mother called to him.

And with one last smile, they faded into the warmth together.

☽ ☽ ☽

When Katsuki woke up, his face was already wet.

Tears slid silently down his cheeks, warm against the cool air of the room as he stared up at the plain ceiling. His breath caught in his throat. He covered his mouth with one trembling hand and screwed his eyes shut as the weight of the dream hit him all at once.

But this time, there was no pain in the feeling.

A soft, steady warmth bloomed in his chest and wrapped around his ribs like a second skin.

Because of *course* his mother would’ve loved Izuku. There was never a version of the world where she wouldn’t. Similar to that sappy shit Izuku always said, in another lifetime or whatever, those two would have laughed together. They would have shared stories. Bickered in a friendly way and found common ground.

And just like that, the broken heart inside Katsuki began to mend a little.

Exactly like at the water tower, a single thread of closure stitched into the torn seam of his chest. Then another. Not enough to erase the break entirely, but enough to heal him ever so slightly.

He understood now, full on that it was love that could heal broken pieces.

Not rage, not violence, not revenge. But rather, love was remedying him.

And *fuck*, he never would've guessed it.

He lifted up from the futon and felt the gentle weight of Izuku's arm around him. The smaller man groaned softly from the sudden shift, but didn't wake up. Katsuki glanced down at him and felt all the pain weighing him down suddenly lift.

He rose to his feet, glancing down at Izuku sleeping soundly. Wordlessly, Katsuki wiped his tears and tucked the covers around Izuku. He smiled at the way the other snuggled in automatically, snoring lightly like always.

Eventually, Katsuki settled into the chair by the window. He gazed out, and noticed all the fog was gone. Sun as bright as the love he felt at this moment was pouring out. And for once, Katsuki let himself be basked in it.

He looked around the room and his gaze fixed on the small vase on the window sill. It held a tiny bouquet of bright, yellow daffodils. The flower reminded him of Izuku. He plucked one from the vase as he pondered on his dream.

He re-lived it like it was a real memory, over and over.

And when Izuku awoke, he told him what his mother said.

Katsuki leaned in, brushing soft hair away from Izuku's temple. With deliberate gentleness, he tucked the daffodil behind Izuku's ear. Izuku blinked up at him in confusion. But then he smiled, still sleepy.

"She would have loved you, darling," Katsuki whispered.

For the first time, he could clearly see what his mother would have wanted. But more importantly, he realized he didn't need her approval to live. He didn't need her presence to move forward. What he needed—what he'd always needed—was already lying in that bed beside him.

Acceptance and love. In their most terrifying, beautiful forms.

☽ ☽ ☽

He kept trying to contact Aizawa after that. He desperately needed to hear that old man's voice if Izuku was ever going to live a normal life. But of course—Aizawa didn't answer. Katsuki groaned as he got the same voicemail.

But between his frustration, Katsuki felt the ache in his chest lessen as the day went on.

The bit of healing he gained the last few days demonstrated to him that he could cure himself of pain through the raw, terrifying act of love. The healing was slow and uneven—but it was progress. He realized that he didn't have to carry grief in silence. And that maybe, if he let himself lean into love with everything he had, it would be enough to keep him from drowning.

After that, he made a quiet vow: he would hold onto Izuku.

Because in every scenario where he thought of departing ways with him, it felt wrong.

No matter what version played in his head, the threads binding him to that short stack of a man screamed out when he thought of severing them. Especially the thought of dropping Izuku off with Nana, never to be seen again, tasted like acid. He really didn't want to fucking do that.

But he also didn't want Izuku anywhere near the Vipers or Yakuza.

Which only left one, real option.

While his heart bloomed at the idea, his mind tugged him back to the looming guilt still hanging overhead.

It reminded him of what transpired a week ago: the deal he'd nearly committed to with Tomura.

And the fact Izuku didn't know it had occurred.

They were now polishing the floors in one of the sauna rooms, side by side. Steam rose faintly around them in soft spirals and Izuku hadn't taken the daffodil out of his hair. It was still neatly tucked behind his ear, absurdly bright in the haze of the bathhouse. The sight of it made Katsuki's heart twist up with an unbearable pressure to come clean about the deal.

However, he kept wondering when would be the right time to confess.

But the longer he waited, the harder it became.

Because the more Katsuki came to terms with how much he loved Izuku, the more impossible the truth felt. And while Izuku had always been the emotionally resilient one between them, Katsuki wasn't blind.

During the past week here at Midnight Sento, Izuku's demeanor shifted.

He'd grown quieter. More withdrawn. He shrunk into himself like a paper figure caught in a steady, all consuming burn. Izuku even began to nervously pick at his thumbs, entirely subconscious and unaware. It was a compulsive act of self-soothing Katsuki was starting to recognize all too easily.

But more so, Katsuki noticed never once did Izuku mention the siblings that he was forced to kill.

And worse, he never mentioned the sibling he gave to Nana.

Learning about the way Katsuma and Izuku parted made him really fucking sad. He recalled how happy Izuku seemed in that mansion, which he now knew was a dressed-up jail. Izuku hadn't been happy because of the riches surrounding him—he was happy because of Katsuma.

Stubbornly, Katsuki wished there was some damn way to reunite those two.

As they polished the tiles, Katsuki stole several glances at Izuku. He watched Izuku's face from the corner of his eye, studying the weight pulling on his features.

Then he looked down at Izuku's thumbs.

A fresh layer of skin had been peeled off. Raw.

Katsuki pressed his lips in a thin line.

Izuku was holding himself together with a very, *very* thin rope.

Hesitantly, Katsuki decided to table his confession for later. Maybe he'd find a better time when Izuku wasn't unconsciously self soothing. Instead, he decided to ask the most important question pertaining to their very dire situation.

"Have you made up your mind about going with Nana or not?" Katsuki questioned quietly. "I know you said you were contemplating it. But I think you really need to take it."

Izuku paused and hesitated. He stumbled visibly on his words and looked down to the murky water in the bucket.

Izuku's brows furrowed together. "I'm still not sure."

Katsuki immediately frowned.

"What do you mean you're not *sure*?" Katsuki bit back. He put down his scrubber and leaned into Izuku's line of vision with a stern glare. He took Izuku's chin with his fingers and lifted his head. "Izuku. You have *gotta* take it. There's no way you will be safe from that evil ass brother of yours otherwise."

"I know but something is keeping me here," Izuku shamefully whispered.

"*What*? What could be so important that you don't want to get to *safety*?"

Izuku chewed on his bottom lip. His eyes skirted to the side before locking on Katsuki's. A moment passed between them and Katsuki's eyes widened at how much sadness was written across Izuku's face.

"...I don't want to leave you, Kacchan," Izuku whispered.

Katsuki's eyes widened and his heart skipped a beat.

He blinked rapidly at the admission, then his whole face softened.

This sappy *idiot*.

"You've been unsure about going because of me?" Katsuki asked gently.

"Is that bad?" Izuku replied. He leaned in and all Katsuki wanted to do was hug him. "I don't want to leave you, Kacchan. I can't. I feel as if I physically *can't*. Every time I even think

about it, my heart hurts in this awful way. How can I go on to a new, happy life knowing you could still be in danger? Or worse, *killed*?"

Katsuki's eyes grew sad, and he dropped his hand. "Izuku…"

Izuku whipped his head away.

"I know, it's stupid," Izuku blurted out. He shook his head and screwed his eyes shut. "I know it's such a stupid damn decision. But I can't leave you like this, Katsuki. I care about you too much. I'm staying and you can't make me change my mind."

A dry laugh almost escaped him.

Of *course* Izuku was thinking the same thing. This stupid nerd even put his foot down as if Katsuki would ever disagree with them staying together. He couldn't stop the tender, lopsided grin that bloomed on his face.

That was his Izuku, he supposed. Stubborn as always, like a damn ram.

"I was actually going to agree with you," Katsuki replied. "I don't want to part ways again either."

Izuku perked up, surprised. He turned back to Katsuki with a bewildered stare.

"Really?" Izuku questioned.

"Of course."

Katsuki smiled and leaned back. He tilted his head as he looked Izuku up and down.

As he did this, he couldn't help but feel another stitch of healing across his heart. They were incapable of leaving the other alone, weren't they? Even in the worst of times, they circled back, ready to have it out one way or another.

"I've had some time to process everything, sort of," he said. "Not fully, but enough. I've gone over a shit ton of scenarios and analyzed all the probable outcomes. And in every one where we're parting ways, I fuckin' *hate* it. It feels wrong, y'know? Like something really nasty is in my mouth and I get this lump in my throat. So, yeah. We should stay together."

His smirk widened as he watched Izuku absorb the information.

His damn dork's eyes widened and then the tension fell from his shoulders as absolute relief overtook him. Izuku's eyes watered and he became so overwhelmed with happiness. He looked at Katsuki like the stars finally aligned, shifting in place just for them.

Izuku asked, "Does this mean we should start looking for places to go since Nana is off the table?"

Katsuki scoffed. "Oh, no. You're *definitely* going with Nana. There's no chance in hell I'm letting that not happen."

Izuku frowned. “But you just said—”

“—I’ve decided I’m coming with you.”

Izuku’s eyes widened.

The silence that followed was vulnerable and painful in its stillness. It stripped everything between them bare, forcing the truth to the surface. Because change always came with pain, didn’t it? Real change tore through the body like a blade, carving out the pieces that no longer served. It dared the body to become something better.

This moment was one of those.

A pivot. A shift in their very souls.

And in that silence, Katsuki made his choice. He would go with Nana. He would follow this path alongside Izuku because he couldn’t imagine his life without him. His mother was always a sound believer in second chances. She started over more times than he ever knew, and at the core, he would always be her son.

And now he was following her footsteps and starting anew with the man he loved.

He pictured their hands clasped across unfamiliar cities and he could hear the laughter they were going to share in the mornings. But more than anything, he could see Izuku’s smile. That bright, stubborn light that always kept Katsuki fixated.

Izuku deserved to smile like that for the rest of his life.

So Katsuki decided he was going to fight like hell to give him that.

“You were right about the situation with me and the Yakuza,” Katsuki continued. “I’m in as much danger as you are. Now that my head is clearer and shit, I can think more logistically. I need to disappear as well if I ever want a chance to be happy and normal.”

“But what about Chisaki?” Izuku asked, unsure. “You said you had a plan to kill him, you can’t abandon that.”

“Forget I ever mentioned that,” Katsuki replied. He viscerally bristled thinking about that stupid fucking deal. “There is no plan. Your safety is far more important.”

“But you’ve been craving revenge for your mother for years,” Izuku emphasized. “If you want, we can go try and kill Chisaki ourselves then try to get back to Nana in time.”

Katsuki didn’t say anything right away.

He took a long, thoughtful pause as he realized Izuku was similar to him in more than one way. Izuku believed in justice, even if it had to be paid in blood. He was probably more thirsty for Chisaki’s undoing than Katsuki was. But Katsuki didn’t want to think about even getting close to the Shie Hassaikai after what he heard.

His fists tightened as he remembered the disgusting kiss between the Yakuza Heir and Izuku.

“Going anywhere near Chisaki is too dangerous, Izuku,” Katsuki whispered, feeling very sure. “You shouldn’t be anywhere near him—especially after everything you told me. It’s too dangerous for you.”

“But…your mom,” Izuku whispered.

“I know,” Katsuki agreed, gritting his teeth when his heart clenched. “As much as it pains me to let that scum keep living, I have to. The thought of never seeing you again is more painful than letting him live.”

He lifted his gaze and grasped one of Izuku’s hands.

He said solidly, “if I have to choose between a lifetime of happiness with you or a brief moment of revenge, I choose *you*. It’s what my mom would have wanted for me, I’m sure. But more importantly, it’s what I want for myself.”

“Are you positive?” Izuku whispered. “I don’t want you to regret this down the line.”

“I could never regret you, Izuku.”

It was the truth.

Never in his life could he ever imagine regretting the one person who changed him for the better.

Katsuki watched as tears gathered in Izuku’s eyes. He looked like his heart was dancing, mending, and flying all at the same time. They gazed at each other full of promises, and Katsuki felt the change fill the air.

“Let’s promise to never let go again, okay?” Katsuki proposed. “Even if we decide things don’t work out between us down the line, I want us to always be in each other’s lives. No matter what.”

He smiled as his own eyes grew full of tears.

“Okay,” Izuku agreed. He smiled back at Katsuki and two tears of happiness slid down his cheek. “I promise to never let you go, Kacchan.”

“Always?” Katsuki asked.

“Always.” Izuku promised.

The longer Katsuki gazed at Izuku, he saw all the heart wrenching versions of him appear before his eyes. They moved through his mind like a sorrowful ballet, one after the other, each cloaked in blood and heartbreak.

Each Izuku carried the unspeakable weight of what he’d endured. They presented themselves in order and then at the end, came a new Izuku. Future Izuku. The Izuku who successfully

came out on the other side of his torment. He was older, wore glasses and was cleansed of all the grime he had to crawl through just to survive.

And Katsuki wanted so damn badly to make sure Izuku got to live in that version of himself.

“We’re finally going to get a shot of that new life together,” Katsuki whispered. “I guess it’s time to really start thinking about that flower shop of dead roses we said we were going to open, huh?”

They both laughed, full of joy.

Katsuki wiped Izuku’s tears away, deciding they didn’t suit him. Izuku nervously chuckled with him as he held on tightly.

“Yeah, I guess we do, don’t we?” Izuku chuckled. “Maybe we should start thinking about a name for it.”

They were finally aligned and all they had to do was make it to Nana. Together.

Izuku began shaking. He tried to calm down, but it was impossible. However, Katsuki could see he was shaking out of happiness. He was trembling because they were finally getting their second shot at running away together.

Katsuki couldn’t help but feel like it was more than a coincidence.

Another stitch knotted along his broken heart and he found himself circling back to the concept of fate. It seemed like no matter how far they veered off from their original promise, they always found a way back together.

What if it wasn’t simply chance that they kept falling into each other’s path? What if it was some sort of sign? What if Izuku was right about fate being real?

Before he could ponder any longer, Katsuki gathered the man he loved for an embrace.

Warm.

That was his first thought. Izuku’s whole body was always so warm, shielding him from the cold. Katsuki pressed in closer and let himself memorize the feel of Izuku in his arms. He reassured himself that this was where he belonged.

Izuku laughed through his tears and held him tighter, pulling him in with everything he had. Katsuki leaned away just enough to gaze into beautiful viridian eyes. He touched the daffodil in Izuku’s hair lovingly.

“Can I kiss you?” Katsuki asked, feeling compelled.

Izuku nodded, hand rising to cradle his cheek. “Please do.”

They leaned in.

Their lips met, and it felt like finally—*finally*—they were home.

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki was floating on cloud fucking nine.

Was this what sheer bliss felt like? If so, he never wanted to come down—ever.

When he wasn't leaving a voicemail in Aizawa's mailbox, the rest of the day passed by in a haze.

He and Izuku held hands the entire time, probably radiating a disgustingly sweet aura wherever they went. But Katsuki didn't give a shit. He didn't want to let go, so he didn't. He held Izuku's hand in the hallway. Then again on their way to lunch. And again throughout the meal.

He kept sneaking glances like a lovesick fool. And every time Izuku caught him, he blushed the prettiest goddamn pink Katsuki had ever seen.

Fuck. He was done for. Absolutely, stupidly *gone*.

Everyone else at the table faded into background noise as he started free-falling into daydreams about the future. He fed Izuku his strawberries and began picturing them berry picking together. Izuku lit up every time the sweet fruit hit his tongue. Katsuki made a mental note to keep Izuku fed strawberries all his life.

But then their little honeymoon daze shattered when someone mentioned a bet.

Apparently, the bathhouse employees had been trying to guess what they *were* to each other?

He bit back a snarl when he realized how nosy they all were.

"I guessed best friends," Takeyama admitted with a smile, her chin propped in her hand as she leaned forward. "But now I'm unsure. I don't think best friends feed each other like that."

Sekijiro, massive and red-faced with amusement, barked a laugh. "I guessed boyfriends of the sorts with a complicated past. I see the way you two are with each other. It's very soft."

"I think you two are exes," Ryoku added bluntly, arms crossed. "Not to be rude but the tension was thick enough to cut with a knife. It was choking us all for the last week on top of everything."

"So—which is it?" Takeyama pressed, her voice light, but her curiosity sharp.

Katsuki and Izuku sat frozen in place, mid-bite.

They both blinked as if they'd been caught in some kind of weird domestic sting operation. They glanced at each other helplessly. Izuku gave a tiny shrug, surrendering without a word. Katsuki exhaled through his nose, rubbed at his cheek, and muttered under his breath like it pained him.

“Well,” Katsuki mumbled. “None of those, technically. We’re legally married so we would be classified as husbands, I suppose.”

The table erupted.

“Oh my god! What!” Nemuri nearly shouted.

Her voice bounced off the walls and earned glances from nearby tables.

Takeyama’s eyes bulged. Her mouth parted in silent shock. Sekijiro looked seconds away from climbing over the table. Ryoku just hummed as though it all made sense now. Then, with the smugness of a man about to win a long-standing bet, Sekijiro turned to Ryoku and held out his hand.

“Pay up,” he commanded, grinning ear to ear. “Guessing that they were boyfriends was close enough.”

Ryoku shoved his hand away with a snort. “Absolutely not. Married is not the same as dating.”

“Wait, you’re really married?” Nemuri asked, eyes scanning them. “For how long?”

“I—I guess about five months now,” Izuku answered, cheeks red as he turned toward Katsuki.

Katsuki glanced down at him, eyes sweeping lazily over his legal spouse like he was the luckiest bastard alive. His lips curled into a little smile as he soaked Izuku in.

“But we’ve known each other a long time,” Izuku added, voice gentler now.

“Ah, so you’re still newlyweds,” Takeyama cooed, her hands clasped under her chin like she was watching the build up of a romantic drama. “This is so cute. You must tell me about your first date. I always love hearing about them when people are married.”

Izuku froze. Katsuki stiffened.

They hadn’t had a first date—not in the traditional sense. Their love story was a chaotic tangle of shared trauma. But, for some reason, the concept of never having a first date bothered Katsuki. Especially given how much of a romantic Izuku was.

“Our timeline has been complicated given, y’know, life circumstances,” Katsuki bit out.

His voice snapped sharp with a sudden defensiveness that screamed ‘back off’. Thankfully, the message landed. The room shifted. Takeyama and Sekijiro quickly redirected the conversation, gushing over what a cute couple they made, their words light but sincere. Ryoku simply smiled quietly, watching them with a calm acceptance.

As everyone talked, Katsuki let his mind wander.

He quietly questioned, did any of what they'd been through count as dates? That entire week in Okinawa felt like one endless pink-hued date. The estate was practically a four-month-long, non-stop courtship with sex scattered like punctuation marks between the days.

He deviously smiled a bit at those memories. He and Izuku had really great sexual chemistry.

Honestly, Katsuki felt like they'd been in a relationship for much longer than five months. Even during all the bullshit with the masquerade and after. And deep down, Katsuki didn't need some stiff formal 'proposal' or ceremony to make it real to him.

But he knew Izuku would want that.

He stole a glance at his legal spouse out his peripheral.

There was a small hint of longing inside of Izuku's eyes.

☽ ☽ ☽

After lunch, they split off to start the second half of their day.

Izuku was dragged into the back rooms with Nemuri for organization duty. She insisted she needed the nerd's precision for reorganizing the supply shelves. His meticulous notes from their first shift hadn't gone unnoticed. And Nemuri, ever the opportunist, put his talents to work.

Meanwhile, Katsuki got saddled with Sekijiro for inventory duty. Mostly because the two of them were built like battering rams and could haul the heavier crates without breaking a sweat.

Katsuki didn't mind. Manual labor was mindless and grounding for him. Which was exactly what he needed with the warm buzz of his decision to leave with Izuku and Nana still swimming in his head.

He tossed boxes of tiles and back-stocked equipment into place without much thought. He worked through the motions with clean efficiency. But every few minutes, he caught Sekijiro sneaking glances at him out of the corner of his eye.

The first time, Katsuki ignored it. The second and third, he clenched his jaw. By the sixth, his patience, already thin on a good day, finally snapped.

He dropped the next heavy box with a resounding thud that rattled the floor.

He straightened and turned with a sharp, unimpressed glare.

"If you got something to say, then say it," Katsuki snapped, tone flat and unfriendly.

"Oh! Sorry," Sekijiro laughed, scratching the back of his neck. He smiled with a guilty charm. "Didn't mean to stare. Got caught being nosy, huh?"

Katsuki narrowed his eyes. "Nosy's a generous word."

“I’ll own that,” Sekijiro chuckled, raising both palms like a man caught red-handed. “But if I ask something, you gonna deck me or answer?”

Katsuki rolled his eyes and huffed. “Depends on the question.”

Sekijiro grinned. “Fair enough.”

Katsuki waved a hand, already regretting this. “Fine. Ask.”

“You said earlier that your timeline with Izuku was complicated.” Sekijiro’s smile faded. His voice dropped and he spoke slower, treading carefully. “What did you mean by that?”

Katsuki froze. His arms slowly dropped to his sides, and he glanced around the room at the towers of boxes.

“Oh, erm.” He scratched behind his head, unsure. “It’s been a lot of…”

Violent miscommunication? Endless, passionate, hot sex?

“…back and forth,” he settled on with a grunt. “To say the least.”

“That boy loves you a lot, I can see it in his eyes,” Sekijiro pointed out. “But I can also see he’s longing for something more. That usually means something unpleasant has likely happened, yeah? Have you gotten the chance to make sure he knows how much you love him?”

The question hit Katsuki faster than he could brace for. Instantly, he flashed back to tracking Izuku down and slamming him into the motel room mirror.

Katsuki winced.

“There’s room for improvement,” he mumbled.

“How so?”

Katsuki shifted his stance, already regretting opening up. But whenever it came to Izuku, his heart felt like it was on a stage for the world to see.

“I’m not exactly the lovey-dovey type,” he said, giving an inch of vulnerability. “I suck with words. So all that romantic crap doesn’t come easy.”

“But you’re trying?” Sekijiro asked.

Katsuki scratched the back of his neck. “Yeah. Izuku likes that stuff, so I’m trying to get better. I dunno, maybe I’ll learn how to write poetry or some shit for him.”

Sekijiro beamed. “You don’t need poetry. If you’re not good with words, use action.”

Katsuki paused. “Huh?”

“Romance isn’t about saying the right thing,” he lectured, voice warm with conviction. “It’s about doing the right thing. Expressing yourself with gestures.”

“What do you mean by gestures?”

“Big romantic ones,” Sekijiro exclaimed proudly. “My husband’s a hopeless romantic too! So I cook for him. He loves it when I cook for him. I make massive meals with hours of prep. To him, it’s not about the food, but it’s about the effort. That’s what people fall in love with—the intention.”

Katsuki blinked. “I guess that makes sense. I just...wouldn’t know where to start with being mushy.”

“Then don’t think of it as mushy. Think of it as honoring him. Romance is an act of respect. A good marriage is built on that. Day by day.”

Damn. It seemed like this guy knew what he was talking about.

Nervously, Katsuki’s brow furrowed and he looked Sekijiro up and down. He never would have guessed such an intimidating man like him would be into lovey-dovey stuff. But in the back of Katsuki’s head, he really wanted to know how to keep Izuku happy.

He licked his lips and curiously asked, “You and your husband have been together long?”

“Over twenty years,” Sekijiro answered proudly.

Katsuki nodded. He wanted a marriage like that.

“Impressive.” Katsuki paused, quieter now. “I...I like the idea of honoring Izuku. I think I could be good at that.”

“You already are,” Sekijiro reassured. “I can tell. But the best way to do it is go on dates. That’s the glue. Don’t ever stop dating him.”

Katsuki scrunched his nose. “Dates?”

Sekijiro laughed, loud and boisterous. “Don’t tell me you two haven’t done a proper date night?”

Katsuki cringed. “Not exactly.”

“Ah, young stupid love,” Sekijiro teased. “You should never stop dating your spouse. That’s how you fall in love with every version of them as they change. They’ll evolve over the years, and if you don’t keep showing up for each other, you’ll miss those changes. You’ll also miss the chance to change as well.”

“Hah? What do you mean?” Katsuki tilted his head. “Dates can change me?”

“They can.” Sekijiro's expression softened. “There’s a quote by Dostoevsky: ‘I fell in love because I needed it to destroy who I used to be’.”

Katsuki went still. The words hung in the air.

Destroy who I used to be.

He looked down at his hands. He saw the calluses, scars, and the invisible blood that stained his hands scarlet.

“That’s...kinda beautiful,” Katsuki admitted reluctantly.

Sekijiro nodded. “Let love be the thing that transforms you. If you want to change—if you want to become someone better—then love. Love’s powerful like that. It’ll shape you. It’s just a matter of which way you let it.”

Katsuki huffed a short laugh. “Damn. That was poetic as hell. I wish I was half as good with words as you are.”

“Hah! You’ll get there,” Sekijiro chuckled. “My husband’s like you. Grumpy as hell, but a total softie under it all.”

Katsuki hesitated. “Uh…hope it’s not rude to ask, but…where is your husband? I figured you were with Ryouko or Takeyama. You all seem tight.”

Sekijiro chuckled, bittersweet. “They’re his cousins. We’re all staying here with Nemuri while we lay low.”

“Hate to pry again, but, what do you mean lay low?”

Sekijiro sighed deeply and set down the box he’d been holding. His gaze drifted to the far wall, distant.

“My husband’s in the Philippines, waiting on us. His family owed an old, large debt to the Sumiyoshi-kai. Before the Chisakis brutally absorbed them.”

Katsuki's stomach turned. He had a feeling he knew where this was going.

Sekijiro continued, quieter now. “His father had a deal worked out with the old leader. But when the Chisaki heir took over, he wiped the books. He cleared all the old debts to start his kingdom fresh. Unfortunately, that meant killing everyone who couldn’t pay up then and there. The Chisakis decided to murder his whole family.”

Katsuki clenched his fists, feeling that dark part of him stir yet again.

“The Chisakis are fucking disgusting,” he spat.

“They are,” Sekijiro agreed darkly. “They don’t forget anything. No matter how big or small the grievance. Ryouko and Takeyama were the only of my husband’s cousins who made it out. We ran with help, and Nemuri hid us here. We’re trying to get to the Philippines, but… the Yakuza have long memories and wide reaches. It’s impossible for us to get out of the country without triggering something.”

Katsuki's voice dropped. He fixed Sekijiro a very serious stare.

"There's a woman who helps people leave when it gets too dangerous," he whispered. "That's who me and Izuku are going to for help as well because we have a similar issue."

"Nana?" Sekijiro smiled faintly. "Yeah. We've heard of her."

Katsuki's eyes widened. "You know her?"

"Not yet. But we'll be leaving with her once the last of my husband's family makes it to Midnight Sento. You see, we are waiting on his mother. She's a retired eradicator, tough as nails. Her body wasn't found that night, and Nemuri swears she's alive. She's the one who tipped us off before the bloodbath."

Katsuki was silent. The story settled like a ton of bricks over his chest. Suddenly, his own problems didn't feel quite so unsolvable anymore—and he realized how many lives the Yakuza fucked up.

His mother was just a drop in the ocean of blood the Yakuza had spilled.

Sekijiro then shook his head, sighed, and smoothed out his shirt.

"But back to what I was saying," he said, pushing himself forward. "Run into love and go on dates. I think it'll help a lot."

Katsuki hesitantly smiled. "Alright. I'll try."

They continued on their shift, and the small lecture stuck deep in his thoughts.

When they finished, Sekijiro left him, but his advice did not.

Katsuki strolled around the area as he wondered how to begin asking Izuku on a date. He tried to think what type of date a cute nerd like Izuku would enjoy. He immediately got a few ideas, but groaned when he realized they were stuck in this damn bathhouse until further notice.

Right as he was brainstorming, he stumbled in the back of a storage closet. He stopped when he found flowers that were meant for one of the sauna rooms. They were bright, yellow flowers all organized by type. Daffodils, marigolds and yellow roses.

Katsuki nervously stepped forward.

I ran into love because I needed it to destroy who I used to be.

Quietly, Katsuki began to assemble a bouquet.

☽ ☽ ☽

Asking Izuku on a date was the most natural thing Katsuki had ever done.

The words slipped out like they'd been waiting on his tongue since Vienna.

Izuku lit up at the offer. He clutched the little bouquet of yellow flowers Katsuki handed over like it was made of gold. When Izuku blushed and smiled, the tension deep inside Katsuki finally exhaled.

The storm cloud hovering over Izuku seemed to part for a moment. It gave way to a bright smile as pure as sunlight. And just like that, the ache inside Katsuki's chest lifted a bit more. It elevated with another stitch sewn across his heart from acts of love.

He went all out for the date. He booked one of the more intimate sauna rooms at Midnight Sento, the galaxy room that reflected stars that were similar to Izuku's freckles.

He'd even asked Sekijiro for help at dinner. He specifically requested one of those "meals made with love" the older man bragged about cooking for his husband. Sekijiro practically screamed with joy at the request, beaming with pride as he prepared every dish like it was a royal banquet.

When Izuku walked in and saw the setup, he gasped.

The whole room was dark enough that it allowed the projected constellations to shine. In the middle of the room on top of a plush black comforter was a kotatsu bearing a purple blanket. Three candles sat in the center and already on the tabletop a delicious meal of various fish, vegetables, and steak was laid out.

"This is amazing," Izuku whispered.

He then smiled like he'd been handed the world. And Katsuki realized, that was all he wanted.

Later, they slipped into one of the bathhouse's tubs Katsuki had reserved.

He transformed it into a bubble bath and sprinkled it with herbal oils. He put candles around it, and gave it that super mushy atmosphere. Once they got in, the water instantly soothed every knot of tension from their muscles.

Katsuki grinned at the sound Izuku made as he sank into the heat. He then reached beneath the surface and took Izuku's leg into his lap. His fingers pressed gently into the tired, freckled skin. He kneaded with care, putting enough pressure to coax soft moans from Izuku's lips. He watched as Izuku's eyes fluttered shut and his lashes kissed his cheeks.

Izuku's head tilted back with a sigh of utter peace.

Then he leaned fully into Katsuki, back pressing into his chest, arms resting on Katsuki's thighs. And in that quiet moment, with skin against skin, Katsuki could have thought of no better time than to ask.

"Well, I guess that leaves one more question for the night," Katsuki whispered in a low voice. "Will you officially be mine, Izuku? If you say no, I get it. I won't be mad."

Izuku smirked up at Katsuki and poked his cheek.

“Ah, I don’t know. It is only the first date,” Izuku teased, lightening the mood. “You already have me naked in a bubble bath massaging my legs. Don’t you think we’re moving a bit too fast?”

Katsuki shrugged. “We’ll move at whatever pace you like.”

“Then of course, I would love to be yours,” Izuku replied joyfully. “Will you be mine as well?”

What a dumb question, Katsuki thought.

“I’ve always been yours.”

Izuku’s eyes filled with an endless amount of love. Katsuki returned it back tenfold. Slowly, Izuku sat up from his position and turned around to face Katsuki. Protective arms wrapped around his body and held him closely. Tangible amount of adoration filled the room as Izuku leaned his weight lightly on top of Katsuki with a soft grin.

“So should I call you my husband or my boyfriend now?” Izuku asked.

Katsuki scoffed. “Husband for sure. There’s no way in hell I’m getting downgraded to *boyfriend*.”

“Okay, good. I’m happy to hear that because I think husband suits you.”

“Damn right it does,” Katsuki replied happily. “It suits you too, Bakugou Izuku.”

☽ ☽ ☽

The next week bled by quicker than Katsuki thought it would. It started with a kiss on the cheek that lingered just a second longer than expected. And after that, the days seemed to slip into each other like pieces of a puzzle finally falling into place.

Katsuki hadn’t meant to fill an entire week with dates, it just happened.

It was like the floodgates were open and he couldn’t stop proposing more dates to the nerd. Or should he say his husband? Heh. His *nerdy* husband. That had a ring to it.

He asked his nerdy husband on more dates and it flowed like water. It was like one moment they were sitting beside each other under the stars in the galaxy room and the next they were walking through the backyard of the bathhouse hand in hand to enjoy some fresh air.

One morning, he dragged Izuku out of bed before the sun could rise.

He wanted to see it paint the sky from the top of the bathhouse roof. Izuku came with him, half asleep and yawning. He was wrapped in one of Katsuki’s hoodies that swallowed his hands. He looked like a sleepy little puppy and Katsuki could barely breathe because of how badly he wanted to kiss him.

“You’re insane for this, Kacchan,” Izuku mumbled, shivering as he pulled the hood tighter.

Katsuki shrugged, coffee in one hand, the other already reaching to warm Izuku’s fingers.

“Yeah,” he replied. “But you’re just as insane.”

Izuku huffed. He didn’t disagree and he didn’t let go of Katsuki’s hand for the rest of the morning.

After that, it became the pattern.

They went on walks around the building in the late afternoon when the world was sleepy and orange around the edges. Izuku told him things he hadn’t heard before. Like how between assignments he used to feed stray cats with his sister Ibara. Or how he always wanted to learn Arabic just to read one of his favorite love poems in its native tongue.

Katsuki listened. He hung intently on every word like they mattered more than anything else he could’ve done that day.

“You know,” Izuku chuckled one afternoon, pushing a piece of takoyaki toward him, “I think I forgot what it feels like to laugh like this.”

Katsuki watched him smile. “Then I’ll remind you every day.”

He meant it—and he proved it.

One date bled into the next. A movie night with snacks as they holed up in the living room area. A lazy morning where they made pancakes too thick and burned half of them because Izuku kept laughing when Katsuki swore at the batter.

Then they had an evening where they didn’t talk at all, just laid side by side and let the silence say everything.

All the while, Izuku was changing. Light returned to his eyes and the stiffness in his shoulders eased. Katsuki noted his laughter was coming easier, like he was letting the pain ebb out slowly.

Katsuki felt it too. The broken heart inside him, once controlled by violence and grief, began to pulse again. The stitched seams of his heart weren’t just healing—they were reforming. He was changing a bit, exactly like Sekijiro said.

“Do you ever think we’ve…always been this?” Izuku asked him late one night as they lay under a shared blanket in the lounge room, the one with the big window that looked out at the sky.

Katsuki looked over. Izuku’s freckles were dusted with starlight. His green eyes shone like glass. He was curled into Katsuki’s side like he’d belonged there forever.

“Yeah,” he whispered. “I think we’ve always been each other’s person. Just didn’t see it till now.”

Izuku smiled against his shoulder. “I see it now.”

So did he.

He saw it in the way Izuku reached for his hand across the dinner table.

He saw it in the way he leaned in for kisses without asking.

He saw it in the way Katsuki found himself looking at Izuku and immediately thought ‘there you are’, like he’d been searching for him his whole damn life.

And every date, every shared meal, every soft word between them carved a path forward through his grief. He worked himself through it rather than around it.

Together, on the nights that felt too heavy, Izuku helped him lift his pain.

One night, Izuku took him to the roof to count stars to take his mind off of it. He really liked that night, and he learned Izuku did that on days he missed Hiryu.

Then another night, when Katsuki found himself sad about his mom and unable to sleep, Izuku noticed and stayed up with him. Izuku listened to him pour his heart out and talk about another memory that greeted him. One that was when he was a kid and he had to spend so much time alone, walking door to door begging for a job.

After he got that off his chest, Izuku took his hand and lifted him up.

They snuck into one of the unused sauna rooms that night. Everyone was asleep, and no one was a witness to their quiet mischief. Izuku took extra blankets from storage and made a fort. He filled it with childhood like snacks from the staff pantry. Choco pies, shrimp chips, and strawberry milk.

Katsuki stared in wonder as Izuku gestured to him inside the blanket fort.

“C’mon, Kacchan,” Izuku whispered like they would get in trouble if they got caught. “I think this will make you feel better.”

And it did. They spent hours there, lying side by side. Their feet tangled as they played card games and made up new rules every five minutes just to win against each other.

“You’re such a sore loser,” Katsuki teased, flicking a Pocky stick at Izuku’s forehead.

Izuku grinned and blushed. “You’re lucky I like you.”

Katsuki smiled, *absolutely* feeling lucky. He leaned in with half lidded eyes and Izuku leaned in too. They shared a soft kiss that tasted like sugary treats. Katsuki pushed in, deepening the connection. When they pulled back, they both were wearing twin blushes that matched.

“Did this make you feel better?” Izuku whispered.

“It did. Thank you.”

That night, Katsuki went to sleep happily in the fort with Izuku. They got yelled at later by Nemuri, but they both took the lecture in stride. The very next day they did it again but made sure to clean up before anyone found them.

By the end of the week, Katsuki loved the concept of dates.

He always believed he was too rough to deserve things like this.

But with Izuku, he wasn't just worthy—he felt like he was meant to be this soft.

That annoying concept of fate trickled in again during this week. It shone in front of him every time Izuku's dimples poked through. Katsuki didn't feel comfortable saying that word out loud yet. But Katsuki was already sure of one thing:

He was falling.

But really, he always had been.

☽ ☽ ☽

By the end of the second week, the two husbands were happily in bliss.

Katsuki noticed that Izuku stopped picking at his thumbs. It made him glad to see Izuku was rebalancing. But even better, he was also opening up more easily about his life at The Viper Academy.

Sometimes they talked about it, and he eagerly listened to all the different stories Izuku had of his siblings. It seemed like Izuku was particularly close with the two he had to kill the night of the Scarlet Masquerade, Ibara and Aoyama. Which made it all the more damn depressing.

But Izuku was able to talk about it, which is what was really important to Katsuki.

They were now in the bathhouse all by themselves. Everyone else went down to the port to watch some fireworks. They were invited but declined. They both still felt too uneasy to leave the safety of the bathhouse.

They sat down on the ledge of the window that jutted out in one of the Sauna Rooms.

The two of them faced each other, knees lightly touching. The window they were looking out of was big enough to nearly cover the whole wall. Nemuri had suggested they go here to view the fireworks, and she was right. It gave a perfect view of the sky near the sea.

Izuku leaned against the window, soaking in the cool surface that contrasted the humidity in the room.

Katsuki studied him pensively.

He looked down at Izuku's thumbs and saw they were no longer red. As a couple, they were more steady this week. He guessed this was a better time than any to come clean about the

deal. Katsuki nervously toyed with his hands. He was beyond terrified.

He didn't want to hurt Izuku, but he didn't want to keep this secret hidden.

Izuku turned to him then, sensing the shift of mood.

"Is something the matter, Kacchan?" Izuku asked.

Katsuki opened his mouth and then closed it. His brows furrowed together, and pain struck across his face.

"I'm…I'm really fucking sorry, Izuku," Katsuki whispered.

"Sorry for what?" Izuku asked for clarification.

"I'm sorry for blaming you, for hunting you, and for trying to *hurt* you," Katsuki confessed. "I'm so goddamn sorry."

He shuffled in closer, and prepared for the blow he was about to land to their newly mended relationship. He searched Izuku's eyes and his heart rate increased. Izuku looked so lost and confused. Fuck. This was going to hurt him so much.

Swallowing his shame, Katsuki held Izuku's hand.

"My stupid ass anger blinded me," Katsuki continued. His eyes teared up as he searched Izuku's beautiful freckles. "I lost control and I wound up becoming something I never wanted to be—I kept…I kept *forcing* myself to hunt you despite this voice screaming in my head not to the whole time."

"It's okay, Kacchan. I forgive you," Izuku replied, a little too easily for Katsuki's liking. "Between Tomura and Himiko, the situation was manipulated beyond our control. If I hadn't listened to Tomura, Himiko wouldn't have been able to steal my letter. I don't blame you at all for the way you snapped."

"But you *should* blame me," Katsuki insisted. His eyes pleaded for a lick of hate from this all too forgiving man. "My temper is so fucking bad sometimes, *especially* when it comes to my mother. She's always been the biggest trigger for my rage, and I exploded exactly like my old supervisor thought I would. And he was fucking *right*—I did take it out on someone I didn't want to."

Suddenly, a wave of tears glossed Izuku's eyes.

Fuck. Katsuki's heart began to twist when Izuku's face crumbled a little—and he hadn't even gotten to the part about his deal with the damn devil.

But still, he pushed forward.

"And Izuku—I-I almost—fuck." A small tear rolled out of Katsuki's eye. "I almost killed you. And then I nearly made a really bad fucking mistake—"

“—but you *didn't* kill me,” Izuku interrupted stubbornly.

Katsuki shook his head. “No, that’s not what I’m saying. I’m saying that I nearly—”

“—Kacchan, *please*. Listen to me,” Izuku cut him off again. He took a deep breath and Katsuki’s heart churned when he felt the trembles come through their intertwined fingers. “Do you still want to hurt me?”

“Of course not,” Katsuki replied.

“Do you think you’re still capable of hurting me?”

“No. I could never.”

“Then we’re okay,” Izuku whispered.

He lifted a hand to wipe the lone tear from Katsuki’s cheek. Katsuki screwed his eyes shut in pain because *why*. Why was Izuku always so damn sweet?

Coming clean felt impossible when the person he loved so much didn’t deserve any of the shit he went through. He took another sharp breath in and opened his eyes. He tried one more time.

But Izuku spoke first. And it came across as if he was desperate.

“What’s in the past, let’s leave it in the past,” Izuku pushed, his eyes pleading for them to go back to their happy state. “The fact that you couldn’t go through with it despite having a perfectly good reason too, shows what’s inside of your heart. I mean, Katsuki. I killed your *mother*.”

Izuku began to cry again, and Katsuki’s heart sank when he felt Izuku attempt to self-soothe.

“That’s not a small thing,” Izuku whispered, full of shame. “But even without hearing about my life, you still couldn’t kill me. T-That speaks *volumes* in my opinion. You didn’t even need to know about the letter or how I was brought up to not kill me.”

Katsuki wearily looked down to their hands.

He saw his husband subconsciously pick at one of his thumbs.

“Izuku…” Katsuki mournfully murmured. “I think you’re brushing this off too quickly.”

“Maybe I am,” Izuku whispered. “But we could both be caught in an endless spiral of sorrys if we’re not careful. At the end of the day, all that matters to me is that you couldn’t do it.” He smiled sadly. “I tried very, *very* hard to kill you in Taiwan. B-But I couldn’t. I wanted to kill you; hell I wished you died in Vienna right after I left you there to bleed out.”

Katsuki shook his head. “But that’s not the same—”

"—*It is.* And if we keep punishing ourselves, we're never going to be happy. Don't you want to be happy together?"

"Yes…I want to be happy with you so badly."

"Then let's."

It struck Katsuki then that Izuku was sidestepping the harder conversations. They'd finally gotten to a better spot, but Izuku didn't want to leave it.

He could see the despair in his husband. The way he clung to their newly found happiness with the same desperation of someone who had just stumbled into a sun-drenched clearing after days lost in the woods. Izuku had found his sunspot—and he wasn't ready to leave it.

But to reach the other side, where endless sun awaited, Izuku would have to venture back into that dark forest of thought. However, right now, Izuku wanted to stand still.

Katsuki wondered what would be more selfish: pushing Izuku back into that forest by coming clean or allowing him to be ignorant to his mistake a little longer?

He honestly didn't know.

"The truth is we both hurt each other, in so many ways," Izuku said sadly. They met unwavering gazes and both of them were saturated with guilt. "We betrayed each other, we broke each other's hearts. And on several occasions have shot, stabbed and, in my case, poisoned each other. But all I want now is to start over because we're at such a good spot. We love each other so much, don't we?"

"We do," Katsuki agreed quietly. "I love you more than I ever thought was possible."

"And I feel the same." Izuku's eyes watered. "And I know our lives are all tangled up, but we can keep apologizing forever if we keep on like this. We're not too far from Nana now, and all I want is a clean slate. I know it's selfish because there's so many crimes I've committed, and I'm very much probably not worthy of a normal life. B-But I want it. I want to be normal, and I want to bury the past."

"You deserve all that, Izuku," Katsuki whispered.

"And you deserve it too, Kacchan. We can be sorry the rest of our lives or we can be happy together and try our best to leave the past in the past."

It was a silent plea.

Katsuki really wanted to talk more about what had happened between Biei and now. But the look in Izuku's eye was as if he was about to dive off the deep end. His husband was making it very damn clear that he didn't want to talk about how his life had blown up. And frankly, who was Katsuki to force him?

He knew he had full intentions of coming clean.

But maybe right *now* wasn't the time to do it.

He assessed Izuku one more time. Then, reluctantly, he resigned. He could do it once they were safely with Nana. At least then, Izuku would be less on edge.

He smiled the best he could and nodded.

"Okay," Katsuki whispered, voice laced with pain. "Past is in the past from here on out. I forgot you can be so damn wise."

"Only sometimes." Izuku smiled.

"More than sometimes."

He shifted their hands and completely covered the thumb that Izuku was picking at. He blocked the self destructive habit gently, stopping the tick without interrupting the moment.

Izuku smiled at him, glad that Katsuki wasn't pushing him.

Right on cue, the fireworks went off.

A crackle tore through the air like thunder. It was followed by bursts of blue, red, and violet that splashed across the sky. The colors rained down across the misted windows of the bathhouse, reflecting across the courtyard tiles like falling stars. Katsuki felt the echo of the sound rumble through his ribs.

They both tilted their heads up toward it, breath fogging faintly on the glass in front of them.

Their eyes fixed on the way the light split the sky open. The crackling filled every inch of silence, even inside their little world. The bathhouse trembled faintly with the noise, and yet it didn't feel intrusive. It felt like the world was making space for them.

Katsuki didn't say anything for a while. He simply watched. And he wondered, not for the first time, how this small town managed its grief. It was impressive the people here still found something to celebrate after everything they lost.

He wanted that strength. He wanted to take it and inject it into his bloodstream and never lose it again.

He squeezed Izuku's hand.

They turned to look at each other in the middle of it all. The soft shimmer of fireworks painted Izuku's face in fleeting streaks of crimson and gold. His freckles lit up like stardust.

"I love you, Izuku," Katsuki confessed, from the bottom of his heart.

"I love you too, Kacchan," Izuku replied, smiling.

Katsuki toyed with the idea of fate again, as he continued to stare at his husband.

If it was real, then his fate had something to do with Izuku. They've always been sewn together—every thread made sure to pull them back into each other's orbit, no matter how far they ran.

Maybe it was fate that Izuku pulled the trigger that night. Maybe it *had* to be him.

Because if someone else had done it, they both would be doomed in a way. Izuku would still be trapped in Tokyo, marching towards an altar with Chisaki. All while Katsuki would still be hellbent on revenge, spiraling deeper into the dark. Because if anyone else pulled that trigger, he would have never known it wasn't Chizome.

But instead, they had been torn loose from those paths. Cut free by a single bullet. And now, they were falling from grace in tandem, hand in hand towards freedom.

That day, Katsuki decided he believed in fate because fate brought him Izuku.

And maybe, just maybe, Izuku was his fate.

Chapter End Notes

I hope you enjoyed!! :'D I cried a touch writing this chapter during the Masaru and Mitsuki dream sequence. I dunno why that was really a part that hit me. I really loved developing Mitsuki's complex character for this fic 🥹💕

Next chapter is pretty much all the action parts compressed and then a full lap to where the present left off :') then we're officially in endgame!

Let me know what you think below!! ❤️

Chapter 41: Risoluto

Chapter Summary

Risoluto (Instrumental indicator) — To play with intense resolution/devotion.

Chapter Notes

Helloooo!!!

First, I lied. This isn't a full lap but the next chapter 1000% is. This chapter cuts off exactly two hours before the Yakuza raid the cabin. There's a lot of scenes from Katsuki's POV in this chapter that are important and I think need to be digested separately before we see what happens post-buried alive :')

I hope you enjoy this monster chapter!!

Big thank you to Luna, the LOML for betaing like always <3 Also I will reply to comments on the last chapter soon!! :') had another busy week at work!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 41 — Risoluto

.

.

.

Izuku was his fate.

Six months ago, a thought like this would have scared him shitless. But right now, it was the opposite. It felt *right*. Like a breath of fresh air after suffocating for so long.

He stared at Izuku in the glow of the fireworks, unable to look away. The bursts of red and orange lit up the curves of his face in flashes. But it was the green glow—that brilliant, defiant green—that held him still. Katsuki didn’t blink. He wanted to burn this sight into his brain and never let it go.

Izuku slowly began to lean in. The new resolve in Katsuki’s chest told him to lean in too.

But right as they were about to kiss, the sharp sound of steel whistled through the air.

Both Izuku and Katsuki stopped, eyes shooting open.

A star knife embedded itself in the window between them with enough force the glass splintered on impact. Spiderweb cracks erupted from the point of contact, fracturing across the pane in jagged, deadly lines.

Both of their heads whipped to the door.

“Well, isn’t this heartwarming?” A woman hissed.

Beside him, Katsuki heard the horrible way Izuku’s breath caught.

The intruder walked into the room all the way, sauntering out of the shadows like she’d bathed in them. She had blond hair wrapped neatly in two buns. Her eyes were sharp and golden, piercing in a way that held nothing but bloodlust—and they were locked on to Izuku like bullseyes.

The way she leered at Izuku made Katsuki uneasy. He could see a lifetime of pure, unadulterated hatred.

Katsuki glowered and lowered his chin.

“Katsuki,” Izuku harshly whispered. He slowly began reaching for one of the knives in the back of his sash. “That’s Himiko.”

He didn’t need to hear more. Katsuki’s lethal instincts locked in place within the second.

They rose in tandem and the air shifted the moment they did. The tension strung tighter and tighter as Himiko assessed them.

The twisted scowl on her lips was vaguely familiar. And his heart sank when he realized why. He’d seen her before—in Biei in the goddamn coffee shop.

Himiko took an offensive stance.

Katsuki mimicked her, and the snarl on his face deepened in its viciousness.

Himiko uncoiled her weapon. It was a chain with twin blades melded on either end. She gripped it like it was an extension of her. The daggers along her arms caught the light. Her outfit was bright red, skin-tight and made her look like a real venomous viper more than a human.

Carefully, all three of them assessed each other’s movements.

Two on one should likely work in their favor, but he wasn’t dumb enough to underestimate Vipers. Much less Himiko, who’d successfully fucked them both with her mind games.

In an attempt to draw first blood, Katsuki quickly drew his gun.

But the sound of a second pistol cocking made him freeze.

Both Izuku and Katsuki cut their eyes to the second entrance on the side.

Slowly, another person approached, and Izuku's eyes widened with each step. Katsuki's gut dropped to the furthest pits of hell when another man peeled out of the shadows—and Izuku seemed genuinely scared.

"Aw, don't look so surprised, baby bro," the man chuckled wickedly. "You didn't think The Double Headed Viper would go down that easily, did you?"

Katsuki swallowed dryly at that name. This was Jin.

Izuku killed this guy with a point blank *gunshot* to the head.

How the fuck did anyone survive that? But right as he questioned his own sanity, Katsuki took a closer assessment. Jin was wrapped in layers of filthy, bloody bandages. One covered his left eye and another stretched across his whole head. Both of his arms were wrapped up too—but this guy moved like he wasn't injured at all.

But then—Jin winced.

It was subtle. But Katsuki's sharp eyes caught the movement like a shark smelling blood. Jin was leaning onto one leg more than the other. Which meant it was a weak point Katsuki could exploit.

Katsuki gripped his gun tighter.

"What? You're not going to greet your dear ol' brother and sister after we've come all this way?" Jin taunted. "Especially because you left home in complete fucking disarray. Hell, you could at least apologize for killing Ibara and Aoyama like they were goddamn animals—and trying to kill me."

"You all gave me no choice," Izuku spat.

"There's always a goddamn choice," Jin snapped. "And the choice you made is protecting some snot nosed brats and this outsider over us." He glared at Katsuki. "But I'm sure that's just your M.O. by now. You shot me in my beautiful face and then stole my katana? What a fucking good way to piss me off."

Katsuki clenched his jaw.

Two ticked off assassins wasn't good.

Taking a small chance, Katsuki wearily glanced at Izuku. Izuku glanced right back.

Katsuki took a step forward, keeping his gun aimed at Himiko. He expected her to mouth off too, but she was unnervingly quiet. She surveyed them with the precision of a well-seasoned predator who knew her prey well.

“Please, let us go,” Izuku attempted to reason. “We’re going to be leaving, and I promise you we’ll be out of your lives forever.”

“I think you’ve forgotten who Tomura is.” Jin scoffed. Then suddenly, he pointed at Katsuki, and said, “And by the way, Chisaki wants you buried six feet deep.”

Katsuki frowned, unfazed.

But then Jin pointed his finger at Izuku and said, “and he wants you to come back with us to Tokyo. Fortunately for you, Chisaki decided he still wants his green-eyed *prize*.”

Rage roared loudly inside of Katsuki. He tightened his grip on his gun and his nostrils flared.

Unexpectedly, Himiko laughed. Everyone froze as she did. It started quiet, and it slowly slithered up to a sharp, unnatural pitch. It was so eerie it began to creep Katsuki out. She shook her head like the universe was mocking her then abruptly stopped.

Her lips curled in humor but her eyes were dead cold.

“Once again, you somehow lucked out, Izuku,” Himiko taunted. “Tomura is such a damn persuasive person, isn’t he? It took him nothing but two weeks to convince Chisaki to change his mind.”

“Yup,” Jin sourly agreed. “You did have a helping hand though. That bastard basically got a hard-on right there after hearing that you killed over twenty of your own and two of the Viper Seven. You gave him exactly what he wanted: a family member for a family member—and more.”

“The sick fuck was delighted,” Himiko spat bitterly. “But I suppose that’s what’ll make you two a good match, huh?”

Katsuki cocked his gun at that. “You two are doing a lot of goddamn talking.”

“Yeah, I suppose we are.” Jin sighed and tilted his head. “So. Which way are we doing this, Izuku? The easy way or are we going to have to drag you by that pretty hair of yours all the way back to Tokyo?”

“There’s not a damn chance I’m coming with you,” Izuku warned.

“Ouch! Mr. Viper Killer has got bite now,” Jin laughed. His unnerving smile widened and his one good eye stretched with blood lust. “Good. I was hoping we would do this the hard way.”

Instantly, Katsuki lunged at Jin with brutal speed. Izuku launched himself toward Himiko in the same breath.

They clashed like titans in an earth shattering collision.

The room crackled with the raw power of experienced killers who knew how to slay a room in the blink of an eye. The result was the most brutal, bloody fight Katsuki had ever been in.

His shoulder smashed into Jin's chest. Jin's katana sliced at his calves. Katsuki fired bullet after bullet, gun blazing.

Across the room, Izuku met Himiko's blades with his own, teeth bared and eyes locked.

Jin moved like he was inhuman. His smile was unnerving and far too fucking delightful. Katsuki gritted his teeth as he began to break a sweat far earlier than he anticipated. He cursed. The Vipers were nothing like he'd ever countered. They were trained down to the millimeter of precision and every hit that landed was packed with bone shattering force.

But Katsuki stood his ground.

He ducked, bobbed, and weaved and fired off kill shot bullets in rapid succession. He fought tooth and nail with everything he had. They *had* to win. He'd be damned if Izuku was ever dragged back to that hell hole.

He had a burst of strength and so did Izuku. The fight shifted and they began fighting side by side in perfect harmony. They melted together like two deadly halves of a whole that were absolutely unbreakable together.

It wasn't before long that they executed a new strategy. Izuku took Jin and Katsuki took Himiko.

They were fighting, scraping and bleeding. But Katsuki pushed through the pain as he held on tightly to the concept of fate. It gave him new, untapped perseverance.

Soon, Izuku cut down Jin. He drove Jin's own katana through his abdomen and cut upwards. Blood and screams filled the room and next Himiko retaliated. She slammed her fist into Katsuki's face to the point he was sure she nearly broke his jaw.

And in a blur of hate, she threw Katsuki into a sauna to bake alive.

But the resolve inside of Izuku burned as bright as the one in Katsuki. Katsuki could *feel* it.

Even though the heat inside the machine burned into his skin, he had no doubt Izuku would make it—and he did. Izuku blinded Himiko, and broke himself free from her chain. He rushed to rescue Katsuki.

And in a sharp haze, it all ended as quickly as it started.

Himiko charged them, and Izuku locked her in the same sauna to burn alive.

When it ended, blood was everywhere.

The scarlet color painted the walls, the floors, and both of their bodies.

Katsuki *reveled* in it. The bastards were dead and he couldn't be happier. He was proud that Izuku put them down. But he knew that he couldn't rejoice too long. If those two knew where they were, then they were compromised. They needed to get a move on, *now*.

He turned to Izuku—

And Izuku was horror stricken.

He was hyperventilating, eyes darting around his family's dead bodies. When Izuku's eyes caught on the katana he lodged deep inside of Jin, his breath started coming in unsteady pulls.

Then he stopped breathing all together.

Shit.

Katsuki quickly sprung into action.

He grabbed Izuku by his shoulders and lightly jolted him. The sudden movement jerked Izuku back to reality. He focused his gaze and stared up at Katsuki with glossy, red eyes.

"Hey, breathe," Katsuki desperately urged. "We need to *go*."

Izuku swallowed dryly and took a deep inhale. He nodded and shook himself out of it. He hardened his nerves. He glanced down at the corpses of his brother and sister and a distant seriousness enveloped him. He looked Katsuki in the eye, and it was like a flip was switched.

"We need to cut their jugulars," Izuku instructed surgically. "We have to make sure they're dead and bleed them out."

"Good idea," Katsuki agreed.

Together they walked over to Jin's mangled body. Katsuki unceremoniously kicked him over and Izuku yanked the katana out of his corpse. Without hesitating, Katsuki kneeled down and barred Jin's neck for Izuku. He tilted it precisely, showing the rise of the jugular under the skin.

Katsuki watched as Izuku steadied his shaking hands. They looked at each other once.

Izuku put the blade to the vein and slit Jin's neck open.

☽ ☽ ☽

They moved quickly after that, blood still drying on their skin as they ran through the bathhouse.

They found the rest of the employees bound and bruised, held hostage by a secondary squad of Vipers. The confrontation was brief. Katsuki and Izuku ended it with two accurate bullets.

They didn't waste a second after that. Bags were packed with deepened urgency. All their movements were clipped and purposeful while adrenaline drummed under their skin.

It was only a mild surprise to discover that Nemuri, ever the mistress of masks and secrets, had a hidden chamber inside the bathhouse. It was a concealed space that neither Katsuki or

Izuku knew existed. Its walls were lined with industrial-grade cleaning supplies and, more disturbingly, thick steel tubs brimming with acid sat in the middle of the space.

It became obvious this wasn't the first time the bathhouse employees had done this.

And judging by the efficiency with which they moved, it wouldn't be the last. Ryoku worked with a chilling steadiness. Her gloved hands guided the bloodied corpses of Jin, Himiko, and other Vipers into the bath with a practiced ease.

The acid sizzled upon contact. The sound it made was angry and high-pitched, much like the unmistakably reminiscent of a rattlesnake's hiss.

Fitting, Katsuki thought.

The whole time, Izuku didn't look away. His eyes didn't blink once as the bodies of his siblings melted down to bone.

In the far corner of the room, Katsuki and Izuku were as still as statues. They sat perched on worn metal chairs while Sekijiro silently patched them up. The big man was gentle, but his hands moved quickly. He stitched their gashes with clinical skill and swabbed their wounds with astringent alcohol that burned.

"We need to make a plan to keep out of their reach until we can make it to Nana," Katsuki whispered as Sekijiro treated his blisters. "We're not going to be able to slow down now."

"Is there any place you can think of for us to hide?" Izuku asked wearily.

"No," Katsuki answered reluctantly. "Nemuri? Is there any place you know we could go?"

"I'm sorry, there's not," Nemuri sad replied.

Katsuki exhaled sharply. Dread punched its way through his ribs, and it really fucking scared him. But he kept his head high and his resolve sturdy.

"I guess we're going to have to keep cutting these bastards down in the meantime until I get a call back from my ex-supervisor," Katsuki said solidly. "We're officially on the run."

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki found out quickly that when the Yakuza wanted someone dead, they pulled out all the stops.

Even after they fled from Midnight Sento on his motorcycle, it didn't take long for them to be cornered into a high speed chase. Katsuki's nerves rattled out of control as he maneuvered his bike sharply. He pushed it to the limits in a way he never did before.

Luckily, the combined force he and Izuku were together was unstoppable.

They took down all the Yakuza in the cars in no time. One car flipped over. Another skidded off the road and flipped. And the last came to a stop after Izuku blew their brains out in one

clean shot. But even though they'd come out victorious twice tonight, Katsuki was uneasy.

How the hell did those bastards find them so fast?

Katsuki's jaw tensed as he stood amid the wreckage. Blood pooled beneath the fresh corpses, as his eyes scoured the scene. He traced every limp body and every shattered piece of glass as though the answer might be hiding in the mayhem.

But then it clicked.

He walked himself back in his memory to the morning after the Scarlet Masquerade.

That goddamn Tomura followed him to the hotel. He didn't think much of it then, but now he made a connection that Tomura likely saw him get on his bike. Katsuki's eyes blew wide and they snapped toward the bright red motorcycle parked near the fringe of the chaos. Its paint gleamed mockingly beneath the moon.

"It's my *bike*," he hissed.

That conniving *bastard*. He must've slipped a tracker on him for insurance. Katsuki knew this was true because it was exactly something *he* would do.

"Fuck!" Katsuki let out a loud, disgruntled groan and gripped his hair. "Fuck. Fuck. *Fuck*."

Izuku's eyes widened, recognition dawning in his expression as puzzle pieces began locking into place.

He was probably thinking of CCTV or city surveillance. But Katsuki knew better. That would've been too impersonal for someone like Tomura. Tomura was as sick as him, and would use a more intimate method—more *obsessive*.

"Damn it all," Katsuki cursed angrily. He grabbed his helmet and hurled it at the ground, the crack of plastic against the concrete echoed through the silence. "We're going to have to go dark completely with these fucking blood hounds. No bike. No phone. No contact with anyone. We can't even so much as breathe in the wrong city otherwise they'll send another goddamn squad."

Izuku closed his eyes. He began drawing in slow, shaky breaths to try to steady the panic rattling in his chest.

"What about the call from your supervisor?" Izuku asked between sharp pulls of air. "We can't get rid of your phone just yet."

Katsuki let his head drop and his shoulders sag. "We'll have to play it risky until it gets too hazardous. How are you on ammo?"

"I have a fair number of rounds left," Izuku said, exhaling a breath that trembled out of him. "But not enough for an entire month and a half worth of shoot outs like this. I could only probably last another five ambushes before I'm forced to only use a blade."

“Same.”

Katsuki fell into a grim silence.

He crossed his arms tight as he stared down at the corpse slumped at his feet. He kicked the body over with a muted thud, studying the shredded, road-burned face half-buried in gravel and dust.

“Once we ditch the motorcycle, we’ll be able to buy some time—but not a lot,” Katsuki muttered darkly. “In the meantime, we’ll keep the phone—but only until my shitty ass supervisor calls me back. After that, we’ll destroy it immediately. So, let’s hope he calls before someone tries to take my head off again.”

With shared bitterness, the two of them left their helmets abandoned on the roadside.

Then they walked up to the one car that was still in decent condition. The car was dented but operable. With methodical urgency, they scoured the interior. They felt out for any hidden trackers, laptops, or burner phones. Every device they found, they shattered. Plastic and wires crunched beneath their boots as they made sure there was no way they could be followed.

When they were sure the car was clean, they wordlessly transferred their bags from the bike to the back seat.

“We should drive to the next city over and steal another vehicle,” Katsuki suggested. “We’ll be okay in this, but only for a few hours. But it’ll be good enough to confuse them.”

Together, they returned their attention to the bodies still occupying the vehicle.

Katsuki reached in first and dragged one corpse out by the collar. He tossed the limp frame onto the asphalt with all the care of someone discarding rotten meat. He was annoyed beyond words right now with the Yakuza. When this was over, Katsuki never wanted to see another tiger tattoo.

Izuku reached for the second body. But just as his fingers curled under the arm, he stopped. He leaned in, expression shifting from focused to mortified.

“What’s wrong?” Katsuki asked, instantly on alert.

“This person is a Viper,” Izuku said with so much profound horror that it sliced into Katsuki. “If this Viper is with a Yakuza, then…then that means they’ve teamed up.”

“Oh, perfect,” Katsuki grumbled sarcastically. “Those bastards are officially working together to bring us in.”

Izuku then carefully laid out his fallen family member on the ground. Katsuki noted the way that Izuku was still gentle with his siblings, even after everything. He softly patted down the corpse’s pockets and pulled out a small, silver cell phone.

Izuku entered a pin code and began sifting through the emails.

As Izuku did this, Katsuki glanced at his motorcycle. His husband remained preoccupied with searching for something on the phone so Katsuki did a quick backtrack. He began to pat all over his bike, slightly frantic. He wearily glanced over his shoulder at Izuku, praying he didn't notice. And he didn't. Then Katsuki's hand tucked under the belly of his bike and froze. He felt something jutting out.

Katsuki pulled and it snapped right off.

He stared at it, and it stared back. It was a tracker, and it looked exactly like the kind Katsuki planted on his own prey. He gritted his teeth and crushed it in his hands. His temper began to swell.

Tomura. That *thorough* motherfucker.

It was eerie how similar to him Tomura was in his hunting methods. It was almost poetic—if it hadn't been so terrifying.

Suddenly, he heard Izuku's breath hitch.

Katsuki's head whipped around. Izuku was frozen in place, eyes wide and locked on the screen.

Without a word, Katsuki crossed the distance and leaned over his shoulder. And on the phone was an email—from Tomura.

> From: Mamushi Tomura
>
> To: Tokyo Vipers
>
> CC: One
>
> Subject line: URGENT: Shie Hassaikai Merger under way and Viridian Viper Situation
>
> All,
>
> Thank you for your cooperation over the last two weeks. I know it has been a trying time given the circumstances. The number of Vipers lost to Viridian Viper's defective actions has undoubtedly affected us all. Many missions have been canceled and as a result, some of our clients have pulled their support to seek business elsewhere until we get everything under control.
>
> Because of this, we are down in fiscal numbers. However, after discussing the situation with One, together we have arrived at a solution that would be able to mend this fiasco.
>
> As of now, it is in our best interest to begin pursuing a merger with our biggest clientele, the Shie Hassaikai.
>
> I know this comes as a surprise for many of you. But after much discussion with One, we feel as if it is the best course of action. Once the merger is complete, this will mean our family will function as a faction of the Yakuza rather than assassins for hire. This

union will allow us to recover the number of forces we have lost from the fire and the murders. Additionally, we will be able to recover financially from having clients pull away. We will also be able to gain access to unlimited Yakuza resources that would help us begin preparing a new cohort.

Mr. Chisaki, One, and I met and hashed out a proper business deal. We wanted to make sure this moves forward with all parties' best interest in mind. There have been many conditions set on both sides. However, two large conditions were set by Mr. Chisaki, and they are non-negotiable:

1. The Viridian Viper must be delivered to him.
2. Bakugou Katsuki must be killed for murdering his family members.

As of now, both are a priority. The merger cannot move forward until these tasks are completed. Going onward I will be selectively dispatching you all to complete these checklist items.

I will be answering all suitable questions at the next all hands meeting, which will be scheduled for tomorrow at 18:00 in the Grand Hall.

Signed,

Mamushi Tomura, The Horned Viper.

Izuku breathed out unevenly. The sound caught in his throat like jagged glass. His eyes darted toward Katsuki, wide and deeply shaken.

Katsuki's anger simmered low, ready to blow the lid at any moment.

He read the whole thing. He didn't care that his murder was high on the priority list. He was sickened by how Tomura and Chisaki discussed Izuku. They acted as if Izuku was a bargaining chip. An asset. A *tool* to be handed over once the ink on their alliance dried.

"C'mon." Katsuki's nostrils flared and he looked Izuku dead in his eye. "Let's get the fuck out of here."

☽ ☽ ☽

They drove into the open dark with nothing but the moon. The whole way, Katsuki never once let go of Izuku's hand. His grip was firm, anchoring them both as the car hummed low. They skimmed along desolate roads that stretched out like veins through a lifeless, moon-washed landscape.

Along the way, they didn't speak. There was an underlying tension in the air as the night's events piled up. The fireworks. The fight. Jin bleeding out and Himiko burned alive. Then finally the acid baths and the car chase.

It was a lot for the last few hours.

Katsuki's only comfort came from the way Izuku's skin felt beneath his fingers. He traced slow, grounding circles over the back of Izuku's hand, again and again, trying to keep himself from unraveling.

But Izuku was unraveling. Quietly, cleanly, and almost invisibly.

He was good at hiding the worst of his spirals, Katsuki noted. Izuku was trained to mask emotion the way others were trained to breathe. Still, Katsuki saw it. The way Izuku's hand twitched, thumb pressing rhythmically against his forefinger like he was trying to ease himself with the pressure.

Katsuki's stomach turned.

He hated that goddamn twitch. And worst of all, he hated that he couldn't fix it. He wished he could make Izuku feel secure—but they weren't exactly looking too hot right now.

He made another attempt to reach Aizawa.

But he got the same recorded voice memo. Katsuki left another message, though he doubted anyone would hear it. The phone might as well have been a brick.

Reality was closing in like a trap. They were bleeding resources and time, and the only person Katsuki trusted enough for help had apparently gone off the goddamn grid. If Aizawa didn't call back soon, they'd be left to survive on sheer will and dwindling ammunition.

When they finally made it to the next town over, immediately Katsuki began scouting for a car to hijack. They found one easily, and began to drive further south with no stops.

When they passed a sign that said, 'Welcome to Kitakyushu', it signaled to them that they were nearly all the way at the southernmost end of the country—as far away from Tokyo as possible.

Katsuki's eyes were beginning to droop, and Izuku was dozing off. The adrenaline comedown was hitting them both hard.

All the wounds they sustained from the consecutive fights were beginning to show. Katsuki suddenly felt every damn punch Himiko and Jin landed on him. He also could feel some blisters on his skin sting from being locked in that malfunctioning sauna.

Izuku was clearly feeling it too. His shoulder, which sustained a nasty blow from Himiko, was stiffening.

When the ache in their bones and muscles became too much, it was obvious they needed to rest.

Katsuki drove up to a secluded cliff top and parked the car off in the grass. They were covered by the barren trees, and there wasn't much traffic coming in and out of the mountain road. They climbed into the backseat and used Katsuki's sleeping bag as a blanket to warm them up.

Katsuki sighed and his frosty breath spilled into the air. He pulled out his phone once more, leaned further into the makeshift blanket, and he began dialing the same contact yet again.

This time, it wasn't frustration driving him—it was fear.

He dialed Aizawa again. Katsuki's usually steady hand was beginning to shake. The phone rang. Once. Twice. Again. The tone went on and on, looping endlessly. Katsuki swore it started to sound like a death march—the kind of slow, inevitable rhythm that haunted funeral parlors.

Then: *beep*.

"Sorry, the inbox of this receiver is full. Please try calling again."

Katsuki let the silence stretch for a beat. He pulled the phone from his ear and dropped it onto his lap like it burned him.

"No dice," he said, sadly. "Yet again."

Katsuki watched as Izuku's bottom lip began to tremble, and then it all came crumbling down. His teeth clenched. His eyes squeezed shut. And finally, his shoulders dropped like his body buckled under the weight of the direness they were trapped in.

A broken sob wrenched from Izuku's chest.

Katsuki jolted upright, heart seizing at the sound.

Izuku covered his mouth with a shaking hand and turned away, like he was ashamed. He clearly didn't want Katsuki to see him like this, but the cries came anyway. They wrecked him in full-bodied shudders.

Katsuki reached for him instantly, pulling him close. His arms wrapped around Izuku like they could somehow shield him from all the horrors of the last two weeks. But it didn't feel like enough. Katsuki's chest tightened with helplessness.

This wasn't what he wanted. He wanted to make Izuku happy. He wanted to see that teasing smile and hear that breathy laugh.

"Hey, don't cry," Katsuki comforted. He soothed his hands over Izuku's shoulders. "Shit. Izuku, please don't cry."

"I'm sorry," Izuku whispered back, voice frayed.

He pressed himself into the crook of Katsuki's neck. Katsuki held him tighter, fingers sliding into his hair. He tried to ground him with soft shushes and a light rock.

"I'm so sorry. I can't help it," Izuku stammered. "I-I'm worried now. What if he doesn't call us back? What should we do? Do we find somewhere else to go? Nemuri was all Nana could give us. I-I feel so guilty dragging you into all of this. You were so happy at the estate and now you're back in this because of my mess."

“We’ll get that call back, don’t worry,” Katsuki whispered. He held Izuku closer, and tried his best to believe his words too. “I promise you, we will.”

“But it’s been nearly two weeks,” Izuku’s voice rose in desperation, hands fisting into the front of Katsuki’s shirt. “There’s no way we can keep this up for six more weeks, Katsuki. We don’t have the resources. And if the Vipers and Yakuza are working together that means there’s more places we can’t go and more eyes on us. A-And if they catch us, you’ll—you’ll —”

Another sob spilled from Izuku’s lips. He dug his fingers into Katsuki.

“I don’t want you to *die*, Katsuki,” Izuku wept. His voice cracked on the last syllable. “I don’t think I-I could go on if you—”

“—Stop that,” Katsuki cut in, sharper than intended.

Izuku blinked up at him, startled.

Katsuki’s face was distorted in anger. Not directed at Izuku, but rather all the other bastards that were driving them into a corner. He knew deep down there was no one that could keep him away from Izuku, not even the goddamn Yakuza themselves.

He cupped his husband’s face in his hands and wiped away the tears rolling down Izuku’s cheeks.

“I’m not going to die,” Katsuki promised, voice dripping in that signature, unshakable conviction. “Especially not by the hands of some scummy ass yakuza. And I’m not going to let you come within a fucking inch of that bastard. I meant what I said in those shitty ass vows when I said I will kill anyone who gets between us. That includes yakuza, vipers and it especially includes your fucking brother.”

“You remember what you said during your drunk vows?” Izuku asked quietly.

Katsuki continued to wipe away his tears and nodded.

“Of course, the embarrassment that tape left me with is hard to forget,” Katsuki replied with half a laugh. “Sure, I was plastered, but those words were from the damn heart. And I don’t go back on promises very easily. Now, c’mon. Give me a smile. We did really fuckin’ great today—and we’ll keep doing great until we get to Nana.”

Izuku attempted to smile, but it didn’t form fully.

Katsuki bit his lip as he tried to think of something to lift Izuku’s mood. He looked down at Izuku’s ticking hand and his eyes lingered on the barren ring finger.

“Y’know, I…have something that might really make you smile,” Katsuki said.

“I don’t think anything could make me smile right now,” Izuku muttered.

Katsuki’s lips twitched into a smirk.

He grabbed for his backpack in the passenger seat and unzipped the small pocket on the front. His fingers grabbed hold of a small, forgotten item he'd shoved in the bottom of his bag back in Tokyo.

When he pulled his hand back, he held up the faux wedding ring from Okinawa for Izuku to see.

Izuku's breath hitched and his eyes went unbelievably wide.

"Y-You kept it?" he whispered, disbelief and longing braided into his voice. "After everything?"

"Mhm, I did," Katsuki replied. He twirled the ring around, admiring the emerald in the center as if the rust from wear and tear wasn't there. "I couldn't find it in myself to toss it, even when I was blinded by anger. All I saw was you when I looked at this stupid little gem."

Izuku's smile bloomed weakly across his face, small but so powerful.

"See, I told you it would make you smile," Katsuki teased.

He reached out and pinched Izuku's cheek, earning a soft bubble of laughter. Izuku blushed, looked down shyly, but his smile held firm and radiant. Katsuki leaned in to press a kiss to his forehead, gentle as he could be.

When he pulled back, Izuku's eyes were brighter.

"I actually still have mine as well, Kacchan," Izuku confessed.

This time, it was Katsuki's turn to be shocked. "You do?"

"Of course."

Izuku reached forward and dipped his hand into his duffle bag.

He pulled out the ruby ring.

Something in Katsuki broke open. A short laugh escaped him, hopeful and soft around the edges. Seeing that stupid little piece of metal stitched back a part of his broken heart. The healing came again, smooth and easy. Another piece of closure, and more proof that Izuku really was meant to be in his life.

His husband's smile was dazzling now. It shone through his tears and his dimples showed like stars.

Katsuki swooned at the gorgeous look of joy. He smiled right back.

He took the ruby ring from Izuku and slid it onto his finger. Izuku mirrored him, slipping the emerald ring onto his. Under the soft silver glow of the moon, the fake gems glimmered like they were worth a million bucks. And to Katsuki, they were worth all that and more.

Their hands laced together and Katsuki leaned in for a kiss.

The kiss was slow and rich with history. It was soft at first but Katsuki pressed it deeper. Their mouths moved in sync, and Katsuki was sure this was the only language they ever truly needed. The cold wrapped around them, but the heat they kindled sank straight into both of their bones.

When they pulled back, Katsuki's eyes were set at half mast.

"We'll be okay," Katsuki whispered, voice melting against Izuku's skin. They rested their foreheads together and cuddled further under the sleeping bag. "When this is all over, we'll be living in our house in the countryside. And all this bullshit will be nothing but a bad memory."

Their fingers curled tighter, and the rings caught the moonlight.

Their love had survived the impossible, and Katsuki was sure it would keep doing so.

☽ ☽ ☽

That night, for the first time in a long time, Katsuki didn't dream. His mind was at peace, and in a weird way, he missed the absence of his mother from his dreams. But he supposed this is what moving forward felt like. He wasn't clinging to the past anymore, but rather fighting for the future.

And for a moment, he thought he dreamed of Aizawa calling him back.

Once upon a time, he set an annoyingly loud ringtone for his supervisor in case of emergencies. It was mainly because Aizawa rarely returned calls. He was very much an e-mail guy and more often than not preferred to discuss things face to face.

And he could have sworn it was ringing through his dreams right now.

Then suddenly, it got louder.

When Katsuki opened his eyes, he was confused. Was he still dreaming?

Then when the phone rang once more, Katsuki jolted. He was definitely not dreaming. Immediately, he was shocked awake with a large pulse of adrenaline that set him on edge. Katsuki frantically moved out of his sleepy haze and sprang up. He hastily grappled for his phone.

He answered it and the loudest exhale of relief expelled from him.

"You bastard," Katsuki nearly yelled. "It's about time you called me back, old man."

Katsuki never thought he would be more relieved to hear Aizawa's tired, angry voice. But what greeted him was not the voice of a man who was tired. It was of a man who was really fucking pissed off.

“What the *hell* have you gotten yourself into, Bakugou?” Aizawa exclaimed.

“Did you get my voicemails?” Katsuki asked.

“Get them?” Aizawa snapped back. The octave raised so sharply that Katsuki flinched and so did Izuku. “Did I *get* them?” Katsuki pulled the phone away from his ear and groaned. “Bakugou, I was bombarded with them—while I was on vacation! I just finished listening to every single one. What the fuck is wrong with you—”

The verbal onslaught didn’t stop. Not even when Katsuki was yanking on his boots, the entire car rocking with the speed of his movements. Aizawa’s voice was still going strong on speaker, stringing together obscenities in a way only he could manage.

Katsuki huffed and threw open the door as Aizawa called him a ‘reckless, fucking disaster.’

Izuku made a confused sound.

“Sorry,” Katsuki grumbled to his husband. “Give me one second to calm him down.”

Katsuki hurried out of the car. He shut the door behind him and shivered under the winter winds.

He walked far away from the car so Izuku could keep sleeping.

“—Sixty fucking voicemails and over a hundred text messages!” Aizawa roared through the phone. “Bakugou Katsuki, I genuinely regret ever taking pity on your sorry ass sometimes. You were supposed to be retired. *Retired*! And instead of enjoying a quiet, non-homicidal life, you decide to piss off the fucking Yakuza?! What the hell did you do?!”

“I know, I know,” Katsuki hissed. “I’m sorry, okay? I’m really fucking sorry. I’ll make it up to you and buy you a cake or something—”

“I don’t give a fuck about a cake!” Aizawa shouted. “Answer the damn question or *so help me*—”

“I’ll explain everything in person,” Katsuki interrupted, desperate now. “I promise. I just—I don’t have time right now, Aizawa. I need to go dark soon. I’ve done a good job staying ahead, but it’s getting tight. Really fucking tight.”

He glanced back at the car. His heart clenched.

“I don’t know how many more shootouts I can survive,” he admitted quietly. “I already escaped one by the skin of my teeth. It was a high-speed chase and I had to ditch my motorcycle.”

A long, gritted breath hissed through the speaker. Silence lingered.

“It’s that bad?” Aizawa muttered, his tone clipped.

“Yeah,” Katsuki replied. “It’s that bad.”

A pause.

Then Aizawa said, “If you’re going fully dark, you know I can’t extract you once you cut contact.”

“I know. I figured.”

“Meet me at my cabin in Mount Rausu,” Aizawa ordered at last. “It’s off-grid and built for this kind of emergency. I’ll keep watch on the pass and flag you down. When you get here, you’d better explain what is going on.”

“I will,” Katsuki promised. “I swear. You won’t regret this. Thank you, Aizawa.”

“Don’t thank me yet,” Aizawa growled. “I might slap the shit out of you when you get here.”

Katsuki cringed. Yeah. He deserved a slap from Aizawa and maybe two from Izuku. Maybe more, if he was honest.

The line was quiet for a moment too long. Then Katsuki cleared his throat awkwardly.

“…So,” he mumbled, swaying slightly on his feet. “How was the vacation?”

Aizawa sighed. Then the call cut.

Katsuki pulled the phone away from his ear. He winced.

Well. That went better than expected—marginally.

☽ ☽ ☽

Getting to Mount Rausu was more trying than Katsuki expected.

Leave it up to Aizawa to have a cabin in the most inconvenient place known to man. Seriously. What shit luck that the place they needed to go was exactly on the opposite end of the country.

They began driving there right after he got back in the car.

Along the way, Katsuki could see Izuku was still deflated. The hope in his eyes was running on empty so he decided to try his best to make that sparkle come back. He stopped and got a cheap, disposable camera then began to take pictures along the way.

At first, Izuku thought the plan to make it a road trip was ridiculous. But as they made their pitstops, he saw Izuku’s eyes grow bigger and brighter with every new place they visited.

Katsuki played music low on the car speakers while Izuku hummed along, tapping his fingers against the console. They drove until they stumbled across a park on a hill. The grass was long and the trees swayed gently in the wind. They lay down side by side and stared up at the sky in silence.

“Look,” Izuku pointed, voice lazy. “That cloud looks like a bear.”

“That cloud looks like your hair when you wake up,” Katsuki snorted.

Izuku laughed, half-heartedly smacking him in the chest. “You’re the worst.”

But his smile stayed. And Katsuki caught it in a photo, mid-laughter, cheeks dimpled and lashes low.

They stopped again before nightfall, this time at a hidden waterfall just off the main road. It was the kind of place with no signs, only a narrow dirt path and the sound of rushing water tucked into the trees. Katsuki only found it because he’d needed to pee and they ended up discovering something beautiful.

Izuku stood barefoot in the cold shallows, jeans rolled up to his knees. His eyes were wide like he was seeing magic. Katsuki took another photo. The light hit his skin in golden patches, and Katsuki couldn’t stop staring.

That night, they stopped for rest.

They pulled and parked beneath the stars. For a moment, they both sat on the hood of the car, wrapped in the sleeping bag and each other’s warmth. Katsuki held the camera in one hand and Izuku’s hand in the other.

“Can we take another one right now?” Izuku murmured.

Katsuki smiled and leaned in. They smiled just before the flash went off.

Katsuki had no doubt that in that photo, they looked like love in motion. A little bruised, a little tired—but warm. They stayed on the hood of the car for a while, looking at the stars together before getting in the backseat and going to bed.

On the second day, they switched drivers.

Izuku, to Katsuki’s horror, had no understanding of what a speed limit was.

He cut corners too fast, sang loudly to songs he half-knew, and grinned every time Katsuki cursed at him from the passenger seat. It became painfully clear those photos of him making the illegal turns in Osaka weren’t because he was hastily trying to make a getaway—he actually just drove like that.

“What the hell was that?!” he snapped as Izuku veered into a wild left turn on a busy street.

Izuku smiled sheepishly and gave a little wave to the furious driver behind them. “Sorry!”

“You’re gonna get us killed,” Katsuki hissed.

“I’m enhancing the experience!” Izuku replied.

“You’re enhancing my stress.”

Izuku laughed and reached across the console to squeeze Katsuki's hand. "Then relax. We're fine."

And they were more than fine.

They stopped for lunch under a tree beside a quiet field where wildflowers grew in small, colorful clusters. Katsuki made them sandwiches with ingredients they bought earlier. And Izuku picked petals and pressed them between the pages of the black folder from Nana.

When Katsuki asked what he was doing, Izuku said softly, "Saving them. I want to remember what this part of our journey felt like."

Katsuki didn't say anything. Simply kissed his temple and passed him a bottle of water.

They continued to stop at various places like parks. The seaside. Then they took pictures at a wine vineyard and again in a large meadow. They even went to some quirky restaurant that sold different flavored almonds from Korea.

Even with all the stops, they were still on track for getting to the safe house on schedule.

The long road they were on suddenly began filling up with larger villages, then small towns. The lonesome road transformed into winding bike trails, railroads and two way traffic much closer together.

Katsuki caught sight of a crisp white sign as they passed.

"Welcome to Numata!" it read, cheerful and bold against the overcast sky.

They were nearly at the country's heart now, skimming the edge of Tokyo's outer sprawl.

Izuku tilted his head to read the sign, thoughtful. Katsuki reached into the glove box, yanked out the folded map, and uncapped the red sharpie with his teeth. He leaned back and spread the map wide across his lap.

"Halfway there. Thank fuck," he muttered, dragging the sharpie across the route they'd taken. His spine gave a weak crack as he shifted. "My back is starting to get a crick in it from sleeping in this cheap-ass car. I'm too old for all of this."

Izuku stifled a laugh, stealing a sideways glance. "You're not that old."

"Yeah yeah, I know. But my spirit is sixty," Katsuki shot back, waving the sharpie. "All I know is there better be a warm bath waiting for us at this safe house—and a full plate of food —or I'm going to lose my goddamn mind."

Izuku's hands stayed on the wheel, but his tone softened with curiosity. "Have you ever been where we're going?"

"No," Katsuki replied.

His eyes roved across the map until they landed on a small marker. It was a castle etched in faint ink. He hummed quietly, then circled it with unnecessary flair. He figured Izuku would want to stop there—he always liked places like that, places with structure and weight and history pressed into every stone.

“The old man would never let me crash at one of his private properties,” Katsuki muttered distantly. “He’s way too cagey.”

“What about the other safe house?” Izuku asked.

Katsuki didn’t look up. “What other safe house?”

Izuku blinked in confusion. “The one that was on Oshima Island? That we missed the ferry for?”

Katsuki’s hand froze mid-motion. The red sharpie hovered above the page.

“Right.” Katsuki went still and his stomach dropped. “I’ve never been to that one either.”

Shit.

His eyes slid toward Izuku. And sure enough, he saw the exact thing he didn’t want to see. Izuku’s brows pulled together and there was a faint, sharp glint of analysis forming behind Izuku’s gaze.

Katsuki swallowed. Hard. That deal he’d nearly completed, the one he promised himself he’d eventually confess, crawled back up his throat like acid.

His fingers curled around the map.

“Um, Izuku,” he started. His voice was nearly inaudible under the hum of the tires against the road. “There’s something about that I’ve been…meaning to tell you.”

Izuku turned his head slightly, just enough to fix those sweet green eyes on him.

Katsuki’s heart dropped like a stone.

He could already see it: Izuku pulling over, hands shaking, tears forming, and disappointment thick as oil in the space between them. Or worse: *silence*. That deep, gutted quiet that meant all the joy they’d fought so hard to rebuild would collapse like wet paper.

He opened his mouth and momentarily glanced at the road ahead of them.

And then he saw a parked car dead ahead—way too close.

His eyes widened.

“Shit—Izuku!”

Izuku’s eyes snapped forward like a whip crack.

His foot slammed the brake, and the car lurched forward violently. Their coffee tipped over, splashing across the center console. Katsuki clutched the dash. Izuku's head jarred down with the momentum. The parked car grew monstrously large in the windshield before the vehicle finally skidded to a stop—mere inches from disaster.

The silence that followed was thunderous.

Izuku exhaled slowly and looked over at Katsuki, expression pale and shaken.

"Shit," he breathed. "Sorry—I'm so sorry—"

"Don't worry about it," Katsuki rushed to say, breathing unevenly. "That was my fault."

His pulse thudded painfully behind his eyes. His hands were still braced and his body rigid with tension he couldn't blame on the road.

He took that as a sign from fate or the universe or whatever.

This must've been a blunt way of fate telling him to shut the fuck up. Maybe if he dropped that bomb too soon—it could all crash before they even got to Nana. So he folded the map with one long, deliberate breath. Then he recapped the sharpie and stayed quiet.

He'd wait, just a little longer.

☽ ☽ ☽

After that, it came as no surprise they came across several, insane road blocks.

The moment they got near Tokyo, suddenly multiple 'check points' occurred. Watching the corrupt cops filter through cars one by one sent a chill through his spine. He could practically taste Tomura's deformed dedication.

They ended up ditching the car to travel by train because of this.

During their voyage, he saw Izuku shift from drowning in despair to floating in hopefulness. His eyes were brighter, and his smile was more frequent. He laughed through the long train rides as Katsuki took pictures on the disposal camera.

During these train rides, he got to know Izuku a little better.

His nerdy husband talked his ear off about things Katsuki never gave a single shit about before. But because it was Izuku, he listened and ironically began to care. Somehow, between the first four hour train and the next, Katsuki started giving a damn about different kinds of snakes.

Turns out, Izuku knew a lot about them.

"Wow," Katsuki muttered, a grin tugging at his mouth. "You're like a fuckin' snake encyclopedia."

Izuku beamed, eyes crinkling in half-moons. “I kind of am! We studied them as kids at the Academy. It was part of the training curriculum.”

“Seriously?” Katsuki tilted his head. “Why the hell would you need to know that much about snakes?”

Izuku laughed softly, as if it were the most normal thing in the world. “Because we needed to know how to spot the one snake we aren’t immune to. In case we ever got bitten in the field.”

Katsuki blinked and his smile faltered. “Wait. Aren’t immune to?”

Izuku tilted his head innocently. “What?”

“You said ‘the one snake you aren’t immune to’ What does that mean?” Katsuki asked, brows pulling together. “I thought you were immune to all poisons and toxins.”

“Oh,” Izuku sighed with a shrug and a sheepish laugh. “Nearly. I’m immune to most snake venoms. And I’m immune to common poisons and toxins. Pretty much all drugs that are frequently used in the underground scene and by assassins.”

“So…all the ones that could actually kill you in the job,” Katsuki clarified dryly.

“Exactly.” Izuku nodded. “Full immunity is not really possible. Mithridatism has limits. But The Viper Academy’s been trying to push those limits for decades.”

Katsuki leaned back slightly, eyes narrowing. “What kind of limits?”

Izuku’s smile thinned. “Like Mamushi venom.”

“Wait—” Katsuki stared, his brows furrowing. “You’re not immune to the venom from the snake you’re named after?”

“Nope,” Izuku replied with a light chuckle, scratching behind his head. “Kinda ironic, right? Our founder, One, thought it was poetic. Mamushis are some of the most deadly snakes on the planet. He wanted us to be the same. Fully lethal and feared. But their venom? It’s too potent. If it hits the bloodstream, even a trace amount is enough to start the clock if an antidote isn’t given.”

Katsuki didn’t say anything. His eyes locked on Izuku as he went on.

“It erodes the nerves first,” Izuku explained, softer now. “Then the organs start failing. It’s a slow, drawn out process. Eventually, the body can’t fight it off. It just…gives in.”

“That’s a fucking awful way to die,” Katsuki muttered, uneasy.

“It is,” Izuku agreed quietly. “There were a lot of…failed trials at the Academy to try to build up tolerance. It ended with every test subject dead. One’s been obsessed with cracking it since the beginning, but I don’t think it’s possible.”

A chill settled in Katsuki’s gut.

He didn't like the way that sounded. It was strange, he never thought about it until now, but he always felt a sense of safety with Izuku's immunity. It was nice to know no one would ever be able to sneak up on him and inject him with some toxin and knock him out for more than maybe a few minutes tops.

But knowing that even Izuku had an Achilles' heel didn't feel good.

He shook off the feeling with a grunt.

"Alright. That's enough venom talk for one day," Katsuki huffed. "Can we go back to your weird obsession with plants or whatever?"

"Oh! Sure!" Izuku perked up immediately, his smile brightening.

He slipped right into a tangent about flowers and medicinal herbs. His hands moved as he spoke and his voice was light as air. Katsuki let him ramble, loving that Izuku was getting back to his nerdy ways. But in the back of his mind, he was stuck on that one fact: Izuku wasn't immune to a Mamushi bite.

☽ ☽ ☽

The next roadblock they encountered on their road to Aizawa was the Yakuza themselves. They popped up like the goddamn roaches they were, ruining everything.

While they were on their last train, they both woke up from a nap and noticed it was strangely empty. No one else was there except them and one, elderly man. Then, like a horrible nightmare, when Izuku got up to go pee, that same elderly man struck Izuku with a strong paralytic.

It was all mayhem and blood after that.

Katsuki barely remembered what happened. All he could recall was struggling and punching. One moment they were together, and the next, they were separated by a wall of muscle and suits. The further and further Izuku got from him, the tighter and tighter the string holding his rage in check drew.

Then, Izuku screamed out his name.

"Kacchan!" Izuku yelled.

He looked up in time to see Izuku thrash against two men. One arm tore free and reached for him, fingers stretched for help. Izuku cried out in pain. His arm was wrenched backward into a brutal hold. Two men dragged him toward the rear of the train and the automatic doors hissed open.

As the doors slid shut, Katsuki could see Izuku struggling, lugged away into the opposite cart.

Katsuki saw scarlet.

They tried to restrain him. Hands grabbed his shoulders and arms locked around his ribs. They shoved him toward the far end of the train car like he was just another corpse to be moved.

But they were slow, overconfident men who hadn't earn their arrogance.

He tore out of their grip with channeled violence that he now could tame. His elbow snapped into faces and his knuckles slammed into their ribcages. His teeth gritted as he rammed his knife up through the soft underside of one man's jaw.

Blood spurted everywhere, hot against his cheek. It dripped down the collar of his shirt and he didn't even flinch.

He moved through the scum like fire through dry grass. Every slash was deliberate, brutal and anatomical. He sliced carotid arteries with surgical precision. They screamed, but it didn't matter. Their screams made it better for Katsuki.

He *liked* that they felt pain.

He killed two at once, blade buried in one neck while he slammed another man into the train door so hard the glass cracked with the force of the impact. Another man lunged, and Katsuki ripped the knife across his gut so fast it took the idiot two whole seconds to register he was already dead.

They kept coming.

Maybe they were stupid. Or desperate. Or too full of orders from Chisaki Kai to think for themselves.

The more goons that came at him, the more he slaughtered like animals. His arms were red up to the elbows now, his boots slick with blood and sinew.

Someone dropped a gun in the chaos. Katsuki caught it mid-scramble and turned it against them.

After that, it wasn't a fair fight—not like it really was in the first place.

He shot one through the mouth. Another through the heart. One tried to run and got a bullet through the back of his skull. Red mist burst against the train wall in a pulpy fan. Blood coated the seats, the ceiling, and the windows. It soaked into the floor beneath him until it felt like he was walking ankle-deep in his violent urges.

There was no mercy left in him.

Because they weren't taking Izuku from him. Not now. Not *ever*.

When the last man blocking his path fell, Katsuki didn't even glance down. He was already sprinting towards Izuku.

His heart pounded a furious rhythm in his chest. Every beat was like a countdown. His boots slammed against the metal floor, picking up speed with every cart he crossed. He was a blur of rage and desperation, a creature unchained.

He didn't pause when more Yakuza appeared in his path. He pulled the trigger before their hands could even get to their guns. He kept going and the smoke from his barrel trailed behind him like a veil of death.

He cut his way all the way through until he saw the last door at the other end. It was beginning to close and he shot forward with an urge so powerful he felt like his blood was screaming.

His hand jammed in the thin closing, clutching the door. His muscles were shaking. His jaw was locked. He gritted his teeth and ripped that damn door back open. The metal screamed and the bolts snapped. The gears inside cracked under his fury, sparking as he shoved the mechanism open with brute force alone.

"Wh-What the hell?!" one of the men shouted, but that was all he managed.

Katsuki slammed into the largest thug like a battering ram. The other two scrambled, fumbling to raise their weapons. But Katsuki didn't give them the time. He hoisted the first body like a ragdoll, shielding himself as bullets punched into muscle and flesh. The man jerked, gurgled, and went limp in Katsuki's arms. But Katsuki only snarled. Blood streaked down his face and his eyes glowed with murder.

The second goon didn't even have time to flinch before Katsuki dropped the dead weight.

He raised the stolen gun, and sent a bullet straight between his eyes.

The body dropped and the elderly Yakuza man turned to flee.

Katsuki grabbed him by the collar, spun him, and threw him into the metal wall hard enough to rattle the cart. The man crumpled, throwing a coughing fit until Katsuki silenced him with a fist that shattered his nose and split his lips wide open.

The older gangster tried to pull out his gun but Katsuki seized his wrist. He twisted and snapped it so hard the bone cracked through skin with a sickening pop. The gun dropped uselessly, and the man screamed. Katsuki slammed him against the wall again. This time pinning him with one hand and unsheathing his knife with the other.

"N-No," the man whimpered and began struggling against him. "Get your filthy hands off of me! I'm a high ranking Yakuza! You'll regret this! Chisaki will make sure you die a slow and painful death for this—"

Katsuki leaned in cruelly and his eyes swarmed with shadows.

He placed his blade on the man's bobbing throat and pushed.

"Chisaki will never get the upper hand on me because I have the one thing he *doesn't*," Katsuki hissed. His voice dragged the same way his knife did across the man's throat. "I have

killer instincts."

Blood poured down the man's neck and he began gasping for life. Katsuki took a large step back and the body slid down the wall. It landed with a wet thud beside the others.

In the suffocating stillness of the cart, all Katsuki could hear was the drip, drip, drip of blood hitting cold steel.

His eyes cut over to Izuku on the ground. His husband was tied up, hands and legs bound with thick rope. There was also duct tape was sloppily smeared across his mouth. Izuku's eyes were bloodshot and watery and looked up at him with mountains of relief.

Katsuki didn't realize he'd dropped the gun until he was already at Izuku's side. He kneeled down, cutting away the restraints with shaking hands and a breathless curse. There were so many new bruises along Izuku's collarbone and needle punctures at his neck. His anger stirred fiercely.

"Are you okay?" Katsuki asked as his eyes darted all over. "Did they hurt you?"

"No, I'm okay," Izuku replied breathlessly.

Katsuki's jaw clenched, but he nodded. He pressed his forehead to Izuku's for half a second before standing and hauling him up. After that, they quickly grabbed their bags, and the two of them jumped the train into the freezing dark.

☽ ☽ ☽

The final stretch to Aizawa's cabin was a brutal, near-vertical, hike up the dead-white back of Mount Rausu.

Katsuki could feel the cold wrap around his spine like steel wire, sinking in like vicious teeth. And the higher they climbed, the more the wind turned against them. It cut through the trees with a chilling temperature that was much colder than before.

With every step upwards, Katsuki regretted only bringing a thin motorcycle jacket. His leather gloves were useless as well, and his damn fingers were beginning to feel like stone.

Half way, the incline grew steeper and snow deepened past their ankles. Below them, the world stretched vast and merciless. The ocean gleamed black and silver, a fractured mirror beneath the sallow moonlight. The crescent moon hung crooked behind drifting clouds like a watching eye, casting a sheen over the water.

There, they came across an overlook that was suspended between the mountain's jagged spine and the starlit sky.

Katsuki and Izuku stopped moving for the first time in hours to gaze out.

Katsuki turned toward Izuku. Snowflakes clung to his husband's lashes. His cheeks were flushed with windburn and his dark hair was haloed by frost. He looked tired, wind-chapped, and sore. But still determined.

“I never told you where we had to meet Nana,” Izuku announced suddenly.

“Huh. You’re right,” Katsuki replied. He tilted his head to the side. “Where do we have to meet her?”

Izuku smiled, small and secretive. “The sunny place.”

Katsuki’s eyebrows knitted together in confusion. Then like a bolt of electricity, realization struck and his eyes widened in disbelief. Okinawa. They were escaping to *Okinawa*—all over again. The reference to their failed getaway made everything click into place in a strange, full circle way.

“You’re joking,” Katsuki whispered, stunned.

Izuku shook his head. He grinned until it stretched across his wind-reddened face.

“I’m not. It’s…It’s fitting isn’t it?” He asked.

Katsuki couldn’t answer right away. He was too shocked.

He stared at Izuku, lips slightly parted and heart thudding quicker with every passing second.

Izuku stood framed by the glow of the moon and the endless, silent sweep of the ocean behind him. He looked like he was cut right out of one of Katsuki’s lucid dreams, standing halfway between the boy he used to be and the man he was becoming.

“It is,” Katsuki whispered.

After that, any last doubts about fate were discarded.

Which is why Katsuki’s heart stopped when Aizawa suddenly popped out and held Izuku by gunpoint with a shotgun.

“Bakugou. Why the *hell* did you bring a snake on my property?” Aizawa jeered.

All the dread in his stomach tripled as he saw the love of his life better so close to that damn shotgun. It was the same weapon he’d seen Aizawa use to blow clean holes through people he did not trust. And given where Aizawa left off telling him to kill Izuku months ago—he was likely to get trigger happy.

“Aizawa, hold on a moment. Put the gun down—”

Aizawa did not.

He snapped the shotgun upwards to catch under Izuku’s chin and pushed up. Both Izuku and Katsuki’s breaths hitched high. Izuku held his position, locked in a dead stare with Aizawa’s cold, hate-filled gaze.

“Bakugou, you better explain what the hell is going on right now or I’m putting a hole through this serpent’s throat.”

During the long train rides, Katsuki had mentally prepared an explanation to give Aizawa.

It was a concise, clear speech that explained perfectly what had occurred within the last several months. He even had planned to sprinkle in a note worthy apology. However, all that flew out the window at the sight of Izuku being held at gunpoint.

All the words he wanted to say began tripping over his tongue. He tried his best to make Aizawa understand the danger and the high stakes that were at risk. But no matter how much he mentioned how the Yakuza were hunting Izuku too—Aizawa remained unmoved. He didn't even so much as blink as his glare cut into Izuku.

Then when Katsuki told Aizawa Izuku was trafficked as a child—he saw a small blip.

Aizawa wavered, but then hardened.

"Even if all that were true, Bakugou, why are you extending your neck for him?" Aizawa snapped, unmoved. "Let him clean up his own goddamn mess."

"…Because I love him," Katsuki whispered.

The confession landed like a sniper's bullet. Aizawa whipped his head towards Katsuki with neck breaking speed and his eyes widened in shock.

He gawked so hard that the cigarette in his mouth dropped straight to the ground.

"And I'm also responsible for his mess." Katsuki shakily exhaled and clasped his hands together like he was praying. "I haven't been truthful about what's been going on since Okinawa, Aizawa. There was a lot more to that assignment and I omitted more than half of it from my report. And he…was also with me while I was at the estate for those four months after."

He bit down on the inside of his cheek until he tasted blood.

"Then after that, I put us in a tight bind because I exploded—exactly like you said I would."

At that, Aizawa stiffened.

His jaw tightened as he asked, "…Exactly in what way did you explode?"

"Well. That massacre that was on the news in Tokyo." Katsuki winced. "The one that was given the name 'Scarlet Masquerade'…"

"That was *you*?" Aizawa growled angrily.

"Uh, yeah..." Katsuki scratched behind his head.

"Goddamnit, Bakugou—"

Aizawa cursed under his breath and immediately snatched the shotgun away from Izuku.

He whirled around like he couldn't believe what he was hearing and pinched the bridge of his nose. Katsuki winced and watched as Aizawa closed his eyes and took in a deep inhale. That was never a good sign when he did that—

Then Aizawa muttered under his breath. It was too low to be audible but Katsuki knew exactly what was being said, 'these goddamn thick headed children are going to be the death of me'. Probably followed by a few choice expletives about Katsuki being emotionally unstable and clinically insane.

Which, in all fairness, was probably true.

When Aizawa turned back around, his face was red with fury and his patience was absolutely eviscerated.

"You're going to explain everything—in vivid goddamn detail—when we get inside," Aizawa lectured sternly. He pointed to Izuku with the gun again. "Tie him up. I'll decide after I hear whatever story you have if he's going to be executed here and now or not."

☽ ☽ ☽

After tying Izuku up, they continued their trek up the mountain to a secret passage.

There, the cabin stood tall and waited for them. When they finally got inside, Katsuki was halfway surprised to find a whole damn welcoming party.

Miruko was leaning back on the couch with her feet kicked up like she owned the place. Denki looked like he hadn't slept in days. Sero was gawking at Izuku. Shinsou and Monoma shot him glares so sharp that Katsuki knew they were gearing up to likely strangle him for this whole fiasco.

But honestly, Katsuki was relieved to see everyone. He was beyond relieved that Aizawa took his voicemails seriously. Knowing the old man, Aizawa didn't fuck around. If there was even a chance that Katsuki was in over his head, of course he would call in reinforcements.

And truth was, they'd been very much in over their heads.

So he and Izuku sat down in the middle of the living room like they were giving a war report. They took turns, tagging in and out at certain points.

They told them everything. From the first time they crossed paths as kids in Tokyo, to the crazy mission in Okinawa, and the absolute hell that came after. They talked about the red folder that shattered both of them and even touched on Izuku's upbringing and how he was trafficked.

They talked about the shit show that was the Scarlet Masquerade. Then they segued into Chisaki.

And then, finally, they revealed their marriage.

Which, caused absolute chaos. Katsuki took it on the chin though. Everyone was confused, reminding him how much he rejected romance.

“Holy shit,” Sero exclaimed, taken aback. “Bakugou, you’re in love? How is that even possible?!”

Denki was equally perplexed. “You quite literally have shouted ‘fuck romance’ in public several times?”

“Not to mention berated couples who did PDA in front of him,” Monoma muttered.

Katsuki shrugged half heartedly. “Feelings change.”

By the time they were done, Katsuki was hoarse and Izuku looked like he’d been wrung out. After everything was out in the open, the room was stunned and silent. Katsuki worried when he saw Aizawa’s eyes darting between him and Izuku, still assessing.

He was about to beg again, but Izuku beat him to it.

“Please,” Izuku pleaded. “I know it’s wrong to ask for your help. It goes against everything in my being to do this, b-but I need your help—we need your help. Katsuki is the one they want dead and I don’t want him to be hurt. I couldn’t live with myself knowing that he’s in harm’s way because he got involved in my life. If you want something for your time, I can give you all the money I have on my person. I don’t have much, but I can give you everything I have if it means he’ll be safe.”

Izuku bowed low to the ground. He touched his forehead to the rug and pleaded with all he had.

“I know what type of life I’ve lived,” Izuku uttered mournfully. “I’ll never fully outrun it. Forced or not, I still killed hundreds, if not thousands. But if I have any chance to do something right—anything at all—I want it to be making it up to Katsuki. I want to keep Katsuki safe and watch out for him for as long as I live. I-I want to earn my life.”

Katsuki’s throat closed up.

Goddamnit, Izuku.

He wanted to tell his sappy husband that he didn’t have to earn his life. He was allowed to simply live. But he held onto the words when Miruko moved. She walked up to Izuku with her usual swagger, and gazed down with mixed emotions.

“For someone who killed their husband’s mother, you sure make it sound so poetic,” she said.

“I only want to make sure Katsuki is taken care of,” Izuku confessed, voice breaking a little on the words. “That’s all I’ve ever wanted.”

And that’s all Katsuki ever wanted too.

Miruko dusted her white pants slightly. She crouched in front of Izuku, studying him. She gazed into Izuku's eyes, and Katsuki's heart swelled when he saw her approval shine through.

"You're scared, aren't you?" She asked solely.

"I'm always scared," Izuku whispered, voice sad but strong. "But I've learned to push through it."

Muriko stood, turning to Aizawa. "Well?"

Aizawa watched the entire exchange in silence with an unreadable expression.

When he finally stood, the weight of his decision hung in the air. He didn't say a word. He sent a single, pointed look in Katsuki's direction—sharp enough to silence whatever was about to tumble out of his mouth. Then, with slow deliberation, he laid the shotgun down on the table with a heavy clunk.

He circled behind Izuku, crouched low, and pulled a knife from his belt. With a few terse, practiced movements he sawed through the restraints.

The ropes dropped away from Izuku like dead skin. The breath Izuku let out was shaky—but Katsuki's was rougher. It took every ounce of self-control not to pull his husband into his arms.

Aizawa stepped back in front of Izuku, gaze softening. "So what's your name?"

"My name is Izuku," he whispered.

Aizawa sighed from the depths of his spirits and Katsuki grinned internally.

They were golden.

☽ ☽ ☽

Aizawa dismissed them all with the laziest flick of his wrist, like even lifting his hand was a burden too heavy to bear. But without hesitation, his group of colleagues followed the command.

On the way out, Katsuki saw Miruko and Denki spare Izuku kind, pity filled smiles. On the other hand, Monoma and Sero didn't look at Izuku directly. They made eye contact with Katsuki, and shared intense looks of apprehension. Only Monoma tossed one, unsure backwards glance Izuku's way before leaving.

Then finally, the last person to leave was Shinsou.

He stiffened when he caught Shinsou's stare at Izuku. It was heavy with disgust and distrust. Katsuki was expecting this to a degree. Out of everyone, Shinsou always had the most trouble adjusting to new people.

After everyone left, Aizawa gave them a grand tour of the cabin.

It wasn't exactly Aizawa's taste, Katsuki noted. Some of the furniture was a little too colorful, steeped in hues such as violet and dark blue. Aizawa was more of a grey guy. His home in Yokohama was all various shades of grey with a small pop of yellow in the artwork.

At the end of the tour, they stopped right in front of their new room for the next five weeks.

"Now, go ahead and get a good night's rest you two," Aizawa murmured. "We'll talk more in depth in the morning."

They said their goodbyes and immediately Katsuki hopped in the shower. When they both finished and got into bed, Katsuki happily rested his head on Izuku's. He kissed the temple of Izuku's damp head of curls. And then his thumb stroked lovingly at Izuku's waist beneath the sleep shirt.

"We're almost there," Katsuki whispered.

Izuku smiled and turned to give him a kiss on the cheek.

☽ ☽ ☽

If he could put a bullet through the sun, he would right now. Because the way the sun's beams snuck through the window was progressively annoying him. And god, all he wanted to do was rest. But the brighter the rays got, the less he was able to get back to sleep.

He groaned unhappily and sat up.

Aches and pains riddled him from the top of his head to the bottom of his soles. He felt every lick of pain from all the fighting over the course of the last few days compile into one mountainous gust punch.

He looked around the room, and then glanced down at Izuku beside him. His nerdy husband was snoring loudly, like always. And he looked as if he was in a really deep fucking sleep. His mouth was open. He was drooling. And his hair looked like the most adorable bird's nest Katsuki had ever seen.

Being mindful not to be too loud, Katsuki kissed Izuku on the cheek and got out of bed. He proceeded to get dressed in the black sweater and sweatpants Aizawa picked up for him.

When he walked out to the living room everyone was sitting talking. He scanned the area in one slow sweep, and it didn't take long to register the shift in air pressure. As soon as they saw him, everyone went unnaturally still.

Sero's eyes cut down, and he cleared his throat.

Denki quickly swallowed whatever sentence he was in the middle of and awkwardly wave.

Monoma twirled a knife between his fingers. Then he set it down like he was preparing to throw it at Katsuki. Behind him, Shinsou stood with the deepest damn frown. His back was against the wall and his arms were crossed.

Beside him was Aizawa. He was at the kitchen table, leaned back in one of the old wooden chairs. He looked up with a stare that suggested he'd been up all night. And then there was Miruko. She leaned back in the old recliner with a raised brow. She shot Katsuki a look that said he'd walked into the frying pan.

"What the actual hell, Bakugou?" Sero yelled first, blunt as a brick to the face.

Katsuki shrugged and took a seat next to Aizawa. He sighed, folded his hands and pursed his lips. "Yeah. I know. It's all a damn mess."

"Mess is an understatement," Monoma deadpanned. "But in a way, this is unsurprising. You did always have a flair for the dramatic."

"Fuck, man. You're really gonna run off with him?" Denki asked, voice small with worry that didn't suit his usual energy. "Is it safe to disappear off the grid with this Nana lady? What if she's not even legit?"

"She is," Aizawa cut in. All heads turned towards him as he took a slow sip of his coffee. "I'm the one who gave Bakugou the information a long time ago. He said it was for a *friend*." AIzawa glared at him. "Had I known back then he was in this much trouble, then I think some of this could have been avoidable."

"I'm sorry," Katsuki mumbled. He glanced around and caught everyone's gaze. "Really, I am. I didn't mean to drag any of you in this. I didn't know what else to do. Izuku needs help. Like a lot of fucking help. And I—"

Miruko's eyes softened as he choked on his words. Several others were taken back by the uncharacteristic stutter.

"I-I can't turn my back knowing he's in this much danger," Katsuki finished.

Within the next moment, everyone erupted all at once.

Questions layered over concerns, layered over disbelief. Sero asked if he understood the risk, unsure if he was thinking clearly. Denki wanted to know what would happen if Izuku betrayed him. Shinsou said nothing at first, but Katsuki could feel the burn of his stare against his skull.

"I killed five of Chisaki Kai's people," Katsuki reiterated sharply, louder than the rest. "And not just his mindless goons. His fucking *family*. That type of shit doesn't get forgiven, and sure as hell it doesn't get forgotten. If I don't leave the country, with or without Izuku, I'm a fucking goner and so are you guys. You being involved too long will put a target on everyone's back."

The room quieted again. Katsuki let it settle.

"So yeah. I'm going. I know what I'm choosing." His tone was hard, showing his resolve.

"I would understand if you were leaving by yourself though," Denki whispered. "But you're leaving with this guy. And don't get me wrong, after hearing all the shit he's been through, he

needs to leave. But do you really feel safe living with him?"

"Yes," Katsuki sharply snapped. "I told you, Izuku and I were separated once—and that should have never happened. He's meant to be with me. And I know for a fact I'm supposed to be with him."

Denki swallowed hard and looked away. Miruko's eyes softened, if only for a second. Monoma still looked annoyed, but not enough to interrupt.

"So does this mean this is goodbye?" Shinsou finally spoke.

Katsuki turned his gaze to his mysterious colleague. Shinsou's eyes were shadowed but it was clear he was holding back hurt. His frown was pulled taut, and Katsuki recognized that type of frown. It was the one he would always wear when he was trying to override his sadness with anger in order not to cry.

Katsuki clenched his jaw.

Then he said, "I promise once things are quiet I'll find a way to call. Hell, maybe we'll host a reunion in whatever country we land in."

"You'd better," Sero muttered. "You owe us at least a postcard."

"Of course," Katsuki said. "Besides, it's probably better this way. It's not like I had much going for me here. I needed a fresh start after retirement, and let's be honest—I'm not really giving up anything by going. I don't have much of a life left here."

The silence in the room was broken with Shinsou's sharp groan. All eyes turned toward him, but his scalding glare was already locked on Katsuki.

"You don't have much of a life here?" Shinsou repeated. His voice was acidic and bitter. "You really believe that?"

Katsuki met his stare, jaw tightening. "I do."

"Well, I don't," Shinsou shot back. His throat bobbed and his hands curled into fists like he was holding back more than rage. "You're giving up the team, Bakugou. You're giving up *us*. You built a life here—hell, you fought for it from nothing. And now you're willing to throw it all away because you got caught up with some guy whose life is screwed six ways to hell —"

"Watch how the fuck you talk about him," Katsuki snapped, sharp with warning.

Shinsou scoffed. He rolled his eyes, but there was no heat left in the motion—only hurt. "Whatever. You're giving up everything to go—*what*? Be with him on a beach or something?"

The words shouldn't have landed the way they did. But they had. And Katsuki felt the weight of them settle between his ribs like a quiet bruise. Because now that he was looking around

the room he saw something he didn't before. He saw Sero's sad, quiet frown. Denki's teary confused eyes. Miruko's resigned stare and Monoma's stiff jaw.

They all looked like they were already missing him.

Suddenly Shinsou's anger wasn't just bitterness. It was heartbreak.

Katsuki's shoulders lowered. The fire inside him didn't go out but it changed shape.

"I'm not giving you guys up," he said quietly, the tenderness in his voice startling even himself. "I promise I'll be in touch when the coast is clear. I didn't realize you all would miss me that much. I always figured I was, and I quote—'a crazy blond menace with more bullets than brain cells,' right? I think Monoma said once that I was more likely to bite people's ankles than talk through a problem."

His gaze flicked to Shinsou. A faint smirk tugged at the corner of his mouth. "Guess you won't have to worry about your ankles for a couple years."

It was a weak joke, but it landed.

Denki laughed first. Then Sero. Miruko rolled her eyes, and Monoma snorted. Even Shinsou huffed a bitter breath through his nose.

Then Denki's face crumpled in a heartbeat. His grin folded in on itself, and without warning, fat tears spilled from his eyes.

"Bakugou," he wailed, his voice pitching high. "I'm going to miss you so much!"

Katsuki gagged instinctively. "Okay. Let's dial back the emotions—"

But Denki sobbed louder. He cried obnoxiously with such fervor that the tension in the room snapped. Sero cracked up again, and Miruko barked out a laugh so sudden it startled herself. Then her eyes watered too. Sero reached up and rubbed his sleeve across his face like maybe no one would notice the tremble in his jaw.

Katsuki blinked, unprepared.

He wasn't ready when Aizawa wiped a slow tear from the corner of his eye like it was a stray eyelash. He wasn't ready when Monoma turned sharply to the side to hide the way he sniffled. And he *definitely* wasn't ready when Denki launched across the room like a weepy missile and threw himself around Katsuki's neck.

"What the fuck—Denki!" Katsuki barked, staggering back as Denki latched on like a grief-stricken octopus."Get off me! Christ—"

But Denki only clung tighter.

"Group hug!" Miruko yelled gleefully, wiping her eyes as she stood and bounded over.

“Absolutely not,” Katsuki growled, trying to peel Denki’s arms off. “This is not happening, get the hell away from me—”

But it was already too late.

Miruko slammed into him with enough force to knock the wind out of his lungs. She grinned wide even as her cheeks were damp. Then Sero crashed in from the side, laughing and crying. He looped an arm around all three of them. Then Monoma joined, of all people, puffy-eyed and stiff. He leaned up, reluctant, but unable to stop himself.

Katsuki’s arms froze mid-pry.

He felt like he was drowning in limbs and emotions he wasn’t built to handle. Then Shinsou stepped in close. Not quite hugging, but he pressed a firm hand to Katsuki’s shoulder like a reluctant brother who’d die before embracing but meant the affection all the same.

Even Aizawa, standing back with tired eyes, gave a small sigh and let the moment play out.

And Katsuki…stopped fighting.

It took a second. Maybe longer. But he let his fists uncurl. He breathed in the layered, sweat-and-tears scent of his unit and leaned in slightly. The warmth wrapped around him like a blanket he hadn’t known he needed.

That’s when it finally hit.

This wasn’t just a group of coworkers. This ridiculous, volatile, absurdly loyal mess of people was family. And he’d been part of it all along. He’d spent so many years clawing through the world, trying to make something of himself from the heap of mess he was birthed into.

Somehow along the way—he’d built a home in these weirdos.

And he was about to leave that behind.

Not because he didn’t care about them. Not because he didn’t need them. But because Izuku had become another kind of home. Katsuki couldn’t imagine surviving without Izuku now. It would be like ripping out a lung and expecting to breathe.

And maybe that was what made this goodbye hurt the worst. Because it wasn’t a betrayal. It was a necessary fracture in the foundation they’d built together.

So when the group hug finally broke apart, Katsuki quietly wished it lasted longer. He wiped his eyes with the sleeve of his shirt and pretended it was sweat. No one called him on it. They gave him space and smiles.

Even Shinsou.

And Katsuki knew, with more clarity than he’d ever known, that he’d find a way back to them one day.

☽ ☽ ☽

Later that afternoon, after lunch was scarfed down, most of the group dispersed into the quiet of their rooms. Aizawa and Katsuki sat at the old kitchen table alone. They both cradled ceramic mugs in their hands and stared at the dancing fire across the way.

The coffee they were drinking was strong and bitter. No sugar and no cream. Exactly Aizawa's preference.

"You remember the first time I saw you?" Aizawa said, voice low and full of nostalgia. "I think about that a lot. It's…one of my fondest memories."

Katsuki snorted. "You mean when you held me at gunpoint and broke into our apartment? That's a fond memory for you?"

"Yeah," Aizawa continued, tired eyes watching the steam rise. "I think fondly of it because it was the first time we met. And while you have been a real goddamn nuisance, I'm happy you're a nuisance I got to see grow up. Because, *god*, you were so damn skinny back then. Like a twig with a big head and bigger mouth."

Katsuki laughed and Aizawa laughed a bit too. They chuckled lightly before Aizawa sighed and shook his head.

"But I should've sent you to child protective services," Aizawa muttered regretfully. "Or the hospital. Anywhere but this life, really. I regret it so much."

"Then why did you do it, if you regret it?"

"Because when I saw you that day, I saw it in you," Aizawa replied seriously. "The way you looked at that gun was the exact way I looked at it when I was the same age. That's when I knew you hadn't killed to survive—you *liked* it."

Katsuki stayed still and listened.

"You had no outlet for all your anger," Aizawa sighed. "And that anger got a taste of blood. Nothing satisfies that violent urge once it's triggered. There was no saving you from the edge unless someone showed you how to walk it without falling off. And I figured if I didn't teach you to control it, you'd end up another disgraced name in the papers with body counts beside it."

Katsuki looked down at his coffee, the heat still coiled in the ceramic between his palms.

"You're not wrong," he muttered. "You saved me. So…thanks for that."

Aizawa grunted, sharp and quick. "Don't go sentimental on me now. I already feel like shit about it."

"I am going sentimental on you," Katsuki retorted, smirking slightly. "Get over it. You *did* save me. And I'm grateful, not sorry if it makes you squirm, old man. I think—" He hesitated, for a moment, "—if I'd never met you, I'd be dead by now. Or worse."

Aizawa didn't answer right away. But his lips twitched. The look he gave Katsuki then was full of pride, maybe, or something adjacent to it.

They drank in silence for a while.

"Y'know," Aizawa muttered after a long pause. "You've changed. Between the Okinawa assignment and now, I can see you're different. You're softer. It feels like some of your jagged edges have been sanded down in a good way."

Katsuki laughed into his mug. "Yeah. You can thank Izuku for that. The damn nerd makes me soft."

Aizawa hummed. "Good. You needed it."

They sat with that truth and let it settle like silt in deep water.

Then Aizawa asked, voice quiet, "Are you sure he's the one?"

Katsuki didn't have a doubt in his mind. His face softened. His shoulders dropped. And when he smiled, it wasn't bitter or cocky, but warm.

"It's always been him."

Aizawa nodded once.

And that was all the blessing Katsuki would ever get from him. But it was all he needed.

☽ ☽ ☽

Later in the afternoon, Katsuki returned to the quiet of their room.

He stood beside the bed and looked down at Izuku, whose breaths came deep and even. He was wrapped beneath the tangle of blankets cocooned tight around him.

He looked so small like this, tucked in and cheeks kissed pink by slumber.

Izuku's lips parted ever so slightly as he dreamed. His wild hair was a mess, as always, curling over his forehead. It splayed over the pillow in a way that should've looked ridiculous —but to Katsuki, it was perfect. Everything about him was. The curve of his mouth. The way his lashes fluttered when he stirred. Even the way he curled his fingers under his cheek seemed so delicate.

Kasuki smiled a little. Then in that moment Izuku's eyes cracked open, hazy with sleep. Those impossibly green eyes blinked up at him slowly, disoriented and full of trust.

"Kacchan?" Izuku's voice came low, still heavy with dreams. He tried to rise, but his body was sluggish and sore from everything it endured. "Is it time to get up?"

Katsuki leaned down. He pressed an affectionate kiss to his husband's forehead.

“Don’t worry. Keep resting, Izuku.”

Izuku sighed, the sound small and content. He melted back into the bed without resistance, eyes falling shut again as his body yielded to comfort. The blankets shifted as he curled deeper into them, a breathy “M’kay,” escaped his lips, barely audible.

Katsuki crouched beside the bed. He hesitantly lifted one hand, brushing it gently through Izuku’s hair. He caressed Izuku as if trying to soothe away every ache and nightmare that ever touched him. When Izuku snored again, Katsuki faintly smiled.

He didn’t move for a long time.

He stayed there, admiring his husband as he reflected on everything.

☽ ☽ ☽

The next morning at breakfast, Izuku joined them after sleeping for a full day. Izuku was mortified, but Katsuki was glad. His husband’s body must’ve shifted out of survival mode to rest mode. It pleased Katsuki deeply to know Izuku’s subconscious felt safe.

He hoped in the future they would have a lot of days where Izuku slept peacefully from sunrise to sunset.

As they ate, Aizawa remained unusually focused on a mess of documents in front of him. He was scribbling something in sharp, short strokes. It caught Katsuki’s attention—mostly because Aizawa never did paperwork at the table.

“What’s that?” Katsuki asked, because subtlety wasn’t his strong suit and never would be.

Aizawa signed one last line with a practiced flick of his pen. “I was just finishing going over the final details of Izuku’s case.”

Everything stilled. Katsuki stopped chewing. Izuku paused, his fork midair. Even the quiet murmur of conversation around the table stuttered out into silence.

“My case?” Izuku clarified.

“Yup. You’re officially a client of ours.” Aizawa then reached down and pulled out a green folder from under his seat. He neatly tucked away the papers inside and held it up. “Congrats.”

And there it was, as clear as day: Izuku’s eyes and hair matching the green folders he used to despise so much. He wondered if this was a stroke of fate too—so clearly flailing her arms in front of him for years trying to get him to notice that Izuku needed help.

He felt so damn dumb for ever doubting all this cosmetic shit.

When their breakfast concluded, Aizawa passed the folder to Katsuki with more weight than he’d ever handed over anything before.

“This is officially your last green folder assignment, kid,” Aizawa stated. “Make it count.”

Katsuki gave a single nod, stiff with purpose.

Izuku, brows pinched in confusion, leaned in and asked gently, “What does green mean?”

Silence folded over the room. Everyone turned towards him. Katsuki didn’t let go of Izuku’s hand. Instead, he gripped it tighter until he could feel Izuku’s pulse in his fingertips.

When Katsuki’s voice came, it was rough and certain.

“Green means to protect.”

And if green meant protect, then Katsuki would make damn sure Izuku was protected at all costs.

☽ ☽ ☽

The next two weeks at the cabin passed like melting snow. All too quiet, unnoticed, and far too fast.

It was strange how easily Izuku blended into the rhythms of their group. It was like he’d been there all along, waiting for the right moment to appear.

Katsuki found himself silently watching those interactions more often than not. He would lean in door frames or hovering at the edge of the room, taking it all in.

Miruko and Denki, the twin terrors of loud affection and louder teasing, adopted Izuku almost instantly. The two of them trailed behind him constantly, clinging to his side like excitable siblings. They showered him with attention and laughter. Izuku basked in it. He was shy at first, but then slowly he opened up and became more trusting.

It filled Katsuki with a strange, warm pride to watch. He would have never guessed he wanted to see this. The sight of his husband laughing with people he loved. It felt like witnessing two halves of his life gently merge into one.

One of his favorite moments came unexpectedly. He wandered into the living room and caught sight of the scene.

Miruko was perched comfortably on the couch. Her legs were stretched out in front of her, and between them, seated on the floor, was Izuku. He leaned back into her space, relaxed and trusting. His eyes closed in lazy contentment while she gently brushed through his unruly curls. They were snickering about something, voices light.

Katsuki’s heart nearly stalled when he saw the small ponytails she was tying at the base of his husband’s nape. Two stubby little things that bounced slightly with every laugh.

“This should be illegal,” Katsuki said flatly.

He stepped closer with a fake glare and a real smile tugging at the corner of his mouth. He leaned down and flicked one of the tiny pigtails with exaggerated judgment.

“I think it’s sort of cute,” Izuku replied brightly.

His eyes opened and looked up at Miruko with a grin. Miruko matched his energy, her face glowed with mischievous pride.

“Ahh, this is so nice!” she practically sang. “I’ve always wanted to do this with Katsuki, but he never lets anyone touch him.” She shot him side-eyed as if to say ‘*see what you’ve been depriving me of all these years?*’

Katsuki scoffed and crossed his arms. “I would sooner throw myself into traffic than let anyone put pigtails on me.”

Izuku looked up at him sweetly, almost too sweetly. He held up a pair of thin, pink rubber bands like an offering.

“Can I?” His husband asked.

Katsuki’s knee jerk reaction kicked in first. He was about to blurt a loud, “*Hell no*”—but it died in his throat. He hesitated, pinned down by Izuku’s puppy-like stare. Those green eyes were damn near criminal. He swallowed, scowled, and muttered curses under his breath.

Moments later, Katsuki was sitting cross-legged on the floor.

He hunched just enough for Izuku to reach. He didn’t look at anyone else and kept his eyes locked on his husband’s face. He frowned deeply when he found himself blushing.

Izuku grinned cutely as he gathered the top of Katsuki’s hair into two tiny puffs.

Miruko was practically vibrating with glee beside them.

“I can’t believe what I’m seeing,” she giggled. “You’re officially a domesticated man, Bakugou.”

“We’re never speaking a word about this,” Katsuki replied darkly.

They both laughed. Katsuki scowled and he could feel the stupid pink rubber bands tight against his scalp. But as Izuku and Miruko chuckled together, making small jokes about how he resembled a Pomeranian, Katsuki felt a small, love sick smile creep over his face.

He adored Izuku so much.

There were more moments like this during their two weeks in the cabin. Most of them were gentle and made Katsuki feel completely at ease. But he did notice he and Izuku got teased more often than not.

He pretended not to care but it was starting to feel like their entire relationship was the house’s entertainment. At first, he rolled with it. He had thick skin, and Izuku blushed prettily

whenever someone poked fun at them.

But then the ring conversation happened, and Katsuki suddenly *did* mind.

“Speaking of the big M,” Miruko interjected suddenly. Her sharp grin already meant trouble. She pointed with perfect aim at the two battered rings on their fingers. “Please don’t tell me those are what I think they are.”

And just like that, everyone, even Aizawa, lifted their gaze.

Katsuki tensed the moment Aizawa leaned forward. The old man took a good look at the ring on his finger and tightened his jaw. Then Katsuki watched with dread as Aizawa got up, crossed the room in a few deliberate steps, and gently took Izuku’s left hand in his own.

No one said a word as Aizawa pulled a pair of reading glasses from his pocket and perched them on his nose. The entire group watched, stunned, as he peered at the ring with the solemn precision of a jeweler assessing a counterfeit.

Aizawa’s face pinched with disapproval. Deep lines formed on his forehead with every second he squinted at the ring like it personally insulted him.

Then his gaze inched towards Katsuki. It was flat and weighted with judgment.

“Bakugou, I didn’t peg you as cheap,” he chastised, tone unforgiving. “You proposed to this poor boy with a fake ruby? Even with how much I pay you?”

Katsuki sputtered, heat flushing up his neck like a damn geyser.

“N-No!” He barked, flustered beyond reason. “I’m not fucking cheap, you know that!”

He stood up abruptly and stormed across the room. In one swift motion, he snatched Izuku’s hand away and covered the ring with his palm to shield it from everyone’s invasive stares.

“And there was no proposal,” Katsuki muttered sharply. “We got these rings quickly at a street vendor in Okinawa to keep up the ruse. We didn’t exactly have time to take a stroll through Tiffany & Co.”

Shinsou, lounging with his usual air of amusement, raised a brow. “Not even while you were practically on a honeymoon in Biei?”

“I—” Katsuki started, then stopped.

His gaze flicked down to Izuku, and the embarrassment burned out quickly. In its place came the heavier weight of regret. He glanced down at the rusted band encircling Izuku’s finger.

“No. We didn’t…have time.”

Izuku said nothing. But his expression shifted—just slightly. A quiet sadness settled in the corner of his eyes. It was the kind of sadness that made Katsuki want to turn back time to do things differently.

It hit him then, and it hit hard.

In the chaos of simply surviving, Izuku had been robbed of all the small things he probably dreamed about: a proposal, the perfect ring, the ceremony, and the deliberate joy of building a future with the one he loved.

And Katsuki, the dumbass that he was, never asked about those things.

He could picture it if he tried. He saw Izuku curled up with some secret scrapbook, all smiles and highlighters. He probably carefully planned his dream wedding between assassination missions. The dork was hopeless like that. Probably even knew what kind of suit he wanted to wear down the aisle.

Katsuki swallowed hard.

Izuku hadn't gotten to live out a single piece of the romantic part of marriage.

☽ ☽ ☽

That truth bothered him the rest of the week, until it became so big he couldn't ignore it.

So when they were alone again on the balcony, he let the thought slip free.

Aizawa had told them that he used to listen to the town's orchestra from this same spot with his wife. Now, the same delicate music wove its way through the air, curling up to meet them in faint, whispering waves. Izuku leaned gently on the railing beside him, bundled in his sweater. His cheeks touched pink by the cold and his expression was utterly relaxed.

Katsuki's eyes were drawn again to the shabby ring.

"Do you have a dream wedding ring?" Katsuki asked quietly.

Izuku blinked in surprise, clearly caught off guard. Pretty blush bloomed up from his neck and kissed his cheeks as he let out a shy laugh.

"Ha, I do," Izuku replied. He scratched at his cheek, sheepish. "Or I did. You know me, hopeless romantic. B-But what my ring looks like and all that doesn't matter to me anymore. I'm okay with anything as long as you're my person at the end of the day."

Katsuki huffed, gaze dropping to the railing as he shook his head. "But if you could have your dream ring, what would it be?"

Izuku pressed his lips together thoughtfully. His brows furrowed with focus.

"I've always adored 'eternity' wedding bands," he answered truthfully. "The concept and look of them is very romantic to me. The way they loop endlessly with diamonds, or whichever jewel, all the way around. It feels like they truly represent love instead of one, big giant rock. Eternity like infinity. The love just…keeps going around and around, never ending."

He smiled at Katsuki. Then Katsuki, softening with every heartbeat, smiled right back.

“I would love an eternity wedding band made of rubies,” Izuku whispered. He paused, eyes searching Katsuki’s. “Or maybe an amber stone that leans more red would fit your eyes better.”

Katsuki felt his heart squeeze.

Eternity bands. Damn, how was Izuku always this tender without even trying? He made a silent promise right then to get him whatever the hell he wanted for their future redo ceremony.

“…And your dream wedding?” Katsuki questioned.

Izuku shrugged lightly, eyes glittering as they returned to the view.

“Small. Very personal with a few people and the person I love.” He grinned to himself, a far-off look overtaking his face. “I’ve always loved the idea of a wedding on the roof of the tallest skyscraper at night. The city and ocean in the background stretching on and on like the eternity bands…Maybe we’re both dressed in all white with handmade flower crowns.”

Katsuki could see it. He pictured them on the roof top of the highest building. All around them would be hues of orange, pink, and blue. The colors would melt together and it would be like getting married in the clouds.

Birds would sing and best of all, Izuku would be with him.

He envisioned Izuku in a white suit with a warm breeze threading through his curls. Maybe flower petals in his hair and glitter around his eyes.

He probably would look like a damn dream.

“How about you, Kacchan? Any romantic ideas floating around up in there?”

“I never gave it thought,” Katsuki confessed. “But I think I would like an eternity band too. One made of emeralds preferably.”

Their hands found each other in the silence that followed. Their fingers tangled like ivy. They held each other gently as the morning hushed around them.

And somewhere, down in the town below, a new melody began to rise.

It started softly with an opening line whispered from a violin—then built with cautious grace.

Katsuki stiffened. So did Izuku.

In unison, their heads turned toward the sound, eyes wide. Katsuki strained to listen, heartbeat caught in his throat, convinced he’d imagined it. But then came the next few notes, lilting and delicate. Each one threaded into the next with eerier familiarity.

The violins sang to the air, joined by a low, echoing viola. The tempo weaved like silk through the day, bright and aching. It shimmered, alive and unmistakable.

His breath caught in his chest. It couldn't be.

"Is…" Katsuki whispered, barely breathing, "Is that—"

Izuku finished for him, voice full of stunned wonder.

"The Dance Of The Love Birds?"

Katsuki couldn't believe it.

But he was proven wrong.

Clear and unmistakable, the melody drifted through the air like a dream made real. Each note was exact, hitting every childhood memory that was etched into his bone. It was almost the same. *Almost*. Now, something new wove itself through the familiar melody: a viola.

It was low and mournful, wrapping around the violin. Together, the two instruments caught in an intimate, wordless conversation.

The violin called out, tender and yearning.

The viola answered, solemn and grounding.

Together they danced, fragile and deliberate. It was like hearing the echo of two hearts that had always moved in tandem, even when they didn't know it. The music unfolded much like a promise, each note a step taken along the edge of danger.

They sat frozen, the world narrowing until it was only them and the sound.

And suddenly, they were no longer on a snowy balcony. They were children again—laughing under the statue of the broken angel. Their eyes were full of wonder, and their heads were full of bright dreams about the future. The notes fluttered through them, soft as a passing breath. Each high note pierced and each low note cradled.

The final chord descended with the grace of a feather.

When the last note dissolved into silence, neither of them moved.

Katsuki's eyes burned. He hadn't blinked once.

"…Did I hallucinate that?" he asked, voice hoarse.

"No," Izuku breathed. His eyes were wide, blinking hard as if trying to snap himself out of a trance.

"Did *we* fucking hallucinate that?" Katsuki muttered. He leaned over to examine Izuku's mug. "Were we slipped shrooms by that damn Denki—"

“—Kacchan, that was real.”

Izuku finally looked at him. They stared at each other, bewildered, still caught in the remnants of the music.

“How is that possible?” Katsuki whispered.

“Maybe someone else heard the song?” Izuku offered, reaching for logic.

“Yeah,” Katsuki murmured. He nodded slowly. “He could’ve played it for other people.”

But they both knew that wasn’t it.

They’d been there for the entire process. That long winter of fine-tuning every note was too unique. The elderly violinist had gone through several versions until it became the variant they just heard. What existed before their input had been scattered and incomplete. But the final piece, the one that now played from the snowy town below, was unmistakably *theirs*.

“But you have his violin,” Katsuki said suddenly. His voice was lower now, cautious. “You said he gave it to you, right? How could he play this version for other people without his violin?”

Izuku’s brows furrowed. “Maybe he bought another?”

“With what money?” Katsuki countered quickly. “He was homeless. Just like I was.”

“After you left, I gave him all the money I saved for us to go to Okinawa,” Izuku replied.

Katsuki nodded. But then Izuku’s expression shifted.

“But it wasn’t enough to buy another violin,” Izuku mumbled.

He turned, back toward the town, and dove deep in thought. Katsuki sat still and strained his ears. He searched for the music again, hoping to find some proof of what they had heard. He felt crazed a bit, wishing with everything he had that they could hear it once more.

But the melody was gone.

Katsuki was the first to move. He stepped away from the railing and slipped inside. The warmth of the fire was a stark contrast to the chill still clinging to his shoulders. Izuku followed without a word. They closed the balcony door behind them and sat down on the couch, side by side.

No words passed between them.

They simply watched the fire and held the silence.

“How’d you like it?” Aizawa suddenly asked.

Their heads turned in tandem. Aizawa sat across the living room in his usual reading chair. A book was open in his lap. He looked calm—completely unaware of their turmoil.

Izuku blinked, caught off guard. Katsuki cleared his throat and straightened his spine.

"We…" Katsuki began, the words dragging out of his mouth. "…We really liked it."

Aizawa frowned, unconvinced. "Are you sure? You look like you've seen a ghost."

Izuku forced a smile. "We did like it," he said gently, trying to sound steady. "It was magical. Thank you for telling us about it."

That seemed to satisfy Aizawa. His posture relaxed, and he offered a crooked grin.

"I had a feeling you two would enjoy it," he said. "It's a very romantic time. Makes the impossible seem possible."

"Is there a website or something for the orchestra?" Katsuki asked quickly. "Like can we check out who is scheduled to play or the name of the songs?"

Aizawa shook his head.

"Unfortunately, they're old school," he explained. "The town below is pretty rural given its mountain location. You have to go to Will Call to look at the set list and purchase tickets."

Katsuki scowled faintly. "You mean we would have to go in person?"

"Yes," Aizawa said, now eyeing them with growing suspicion. "Is something the matter?"

"We heard a song we recognized from a long time ago," Izuku explained. "It's silly but we knew the homeless street performer who created it. So it's bizarre to hear it played by a real orchestra."

That got Aizawa's attention. His brow rose with interest. "What's the song?"

The two shifted slightly, exchanging uncertain glances. Then, after a short pause, Izuku started humming first. Katsuki joined him a moment later, and together they tried to reconstruct the melody. It was clumsy and off-pitch, but unmistakably The Dance of The Love Birds.

"Ah." Aizawa nodded slowly. "Yeah. I've heard that play from the town a couple times the last two years."

Both Katsuki and Izuku sat up straighter.

"Really?" Izuku asked, eyes wide.

"Did you ever go see it in person?" Katsuki added at the same time.

“No,” Aizawa replied. “It’s a beautiful melody though. The venue down there has a lot of concerts from new Neo-Classical hits. I think they do tours from select composers.”

The two stared at each other, tension heavy between them.

“Crazy coincidence though,” Aizawa mused. “That’s very neat that you knew who made the song. Do you know their name?”

“No,” Katsuki said gruffly, a bit ashamed. “We, uh, never asked.”

Aizawa let out a long, theatrical sigh and shook his head. “Rude. Even as a child. Well. Maybe you’ll get to hear it again before it’s time to go.”

This felt too simple to let slide by. But realistically—what else could they do?

After that, Aizawa launched into a brief lecture about the importance of asking for people’s names. Katsuki groaned, letting his head fall back against the couch. When the scolding ended, the conversation tapered into a lull, leaving only the low hum of wind.

Eventually, Aizawa stood. With a grunt, he stretched his arms above his head and muttered something about tracking down the other “headaches” on his property to make sure no one had died yet.

Katsuki and Izuku went about the rest of their day.

But the entire time, Katsuki couldn’t stop turning the melody over in his head. The more he thought about it, the more it unsettled him.

“Wow,” Katsuki muttered later that night, still reeling. He turned to Izuku with a crooked smile and gently took his hand. “What a fuckin’ coincidence, right?”

“Yeah,” Izuku said with a quiet laugh. “How crazy.”

It didn’t feel like a coincidence.

It felt like goddamn fate.

But he struggled to admit it out loud. He was gradually coming to terms with it, but it was as if that word was stuck on the tip of his tongue.

That night, they crawled into bed and chalked the entire thing up to an insane fluke. Katsuki closed his eyes and tugged Izuku close into his arms. As he drifted off, he dreamed—not of what had been, but of what could be. In his dream, he and Izuku danced to the music, their steps perfectly matching the rhythm of thee violin and viola respectfully.

Izuku fit the light, reaching notes of the violin. Katsuki grounded them, rich and steady like the viola.

Together, they made the song whole.

☽ ☽ ☽

The next day slipped by before Katsuki knew it.

Denki and Sero remained their usual bright, chaotic selves. Miruko and Aizawa held down the fort with their unique brands of order. Shinsou and Monoma stayed mostly to themselves, content to exist on the periphery of the ever-moving chaos.

Katsuki, meanwhile, rarely liked to leave Izuku's side.

They didn't mention the song again. And The Dance of the Love Birds never returned. No stray notes haunted the wind. No familiar melody echoed in the distance. It was as if the moment had come and gone like a real ghost of their past.

By the second day, Katsuki had convinced himself to let it go.

Maybe it was fate, he reasoned. One final echo of their childhood before they left the country for good. A reminder of everything they'd once been. Or maybe, more dangerously, it was fate calling them down the mountain. Inviting them to chase that unfinished part of their lives.

That last thought lingered, feeling a bit too right. But Katsuki refused to give it room. They were too damn close to getting to Nana. And he wasn't about to risk unraveling it all just to chase some phantom song—no matter how beautiful.

But as hard as he tried to bury it, the thought lingered.

It tapped at the corners of his mind like an unwanted visitor coming by over and over and over again.

On the third night, wrapped together under a thick comforter, Izuku broke the silence.

"I think we should go to the orchestra," Izuku whispered, keeping his voice cautious. "Only for a little bit, if only to see who was playing the song."

Katsuki stirred beside him. The mattress dipped as he propped himself up on one elbow. Izuku rolled to face him with weary but serious eyes.

"Is it really that important?" Katsuki asked after a moment, voice low. "I get it. I do, but…" He exhaled heavily. "I don't want to risk setting anything off. We've managed to stay off the radar this long. I'd rather not give the Yakuza another opening."

Izuku didn't answer right away.

His fingers moved idly along Katsuki's arm, tracing quiet, invisible circles against his skin.

"I guess it's not that important," Izuku mumbled. "It's just…I don't know why, but I feel like we have to close the loop. Especially if we're not coming back to Japan." He hesitated. His voice turned softer, almost like he was talking to himself. "What if it's the violinist?"

Katsuki grew sad at that. “I think he might be dead by now, Izuku. He was pretty damn old and frail.”

“I know,” Izuku replied quietly, his fingers still moved against Katsuki’s arm in small, rhythmic motions. “But…I guess I want to see who else knows our song.”

Katsuki let out a reluctant huff of laughter, shaking his head.

“Our song, huh?” Katsuki parroted lightly.

“Yeah, it’s our song,” Izuku smiled lovingly at his husband, and Katsuki returned the gesture with equal warmth. “Is that weird to say? I’ve always thought of that melody as our melody. It feels weird to have it out there and not know who else is playing it.”

Katsuki stared at him for a long, pensive moment.

Then he exhaled a steady breath and laid back down beside his husband. One hand reached up, threading gently through Izuku’s curls before drifting down the curve of his cheek and then his neck.

Izuku’s eyes fluttered shut beneath the touch, and when they reopened, Katsuki knew he could never really say no to Izuku.

“Okay. You have a point,” Katsuki muttered. “In the morning, I’ll talk with Aizawa and see if there’s any leeway. If he says it’s safe to go, then we’ll go check it out.”

Izuku’s face lit up with gratitude. He leaned in without hesitation, beaming.

“Thank you, Kacchan.”

“Anything for you, darling,” Katsuki whispered, soft and sure.

He kissed Izuku’s forehead, and together they sank into the quiet comfort of sleep. As they cuddled, Katsuki kept bringing his eyes back to the shabby rings on their hands.

He began to form a small idea the longer he gazed at the rings.

☽ ☽ ☽

The next morning at breakfast, much to his surprise, the old man was on board with them going down to the orchestra.

Aizawa gave a lazy shrug while sipping his coffee. He explained that the town seemed safe enough. A few of them had already gone down the mountain for groceries without an issue. So a short trip into town for a few hours shouldn’t raise any red flags. Katsuki felt a jolt of relief and excitement. So did Izuku, who turned to him with a smile so bright it made Katsuki’s heart stumble.

His gaze flicked to the rusted ring on Izuku’s finger, and before he could stop himself, he blurted out, “How about we go at the end of the week then?”

The words tumbled out faster than he meant. There was a slight edge of nerves in his voice that made him wince internally. He bit his lip, silently cursing himself.

“I think that would be a perfect time to go,” he added, trying to sound casual.

But he was sure he failed when he began to bounce his leg slightly beneath the table.

Aizawa’s brow lifted as he caught the movement.

“Why the end of the week?” he asked, eyes narrowing. “It’s not like we’ve got much going on here besides slowly driving each other insane.”

Katsuki froze, his knee locking mid-bounce. Both Aizawa and Izuku were staring at him now, their expressions mildly suspicious.

“I, uh, wanted to ask you a favor,” Katsuki muttered, eyes darting to his plate of food. A slow flush began to creep up his neck. He cleared his throat and added quickly, “Privately. After breakfast.”

Denki groaned dramatically, dragging the sound out with a mock-offended look.

“Aww, come on, Bakugou,” he whined, flashing a wide, impish grin. “We’re all basically family at this point. Whatever it is, just spit it out!”

“I said *privately*, dipshit,” Katsuki snapped.

His voice came out sharper than he intended and he immediately regretted it. A collective groan circled the table. Miruko shook her head into her coffee while Monoma rolled his eyes with theatrical disdain.

Aizawa exhaled through his nose and nodded. “Alright. We’ll talk after everyone’s eaten. Try not to explode in the meantime, Bakugou.”

The conversation moved on from there. Denki launched into some ridiculous story, and Miruko found a new reason to tease Monoma about his table manners. The room was loud and easy, but Katsuki’s mind wouldn’t settle. His thumb kept drawing slow, anxious circles against the rim of his mug.

Every time his eyes drifted to Izuku, he felt the nerves spool tighter in his chest.

Eventually, breakfast wrapped up. Chairs scraped back, conversations trailed off, and one by one, their friends wandered down the hall. But Izuku lingered. He stayed seated, clearly unsure whether “privately” included him.

Katsuki caught the hesitation and gave him a small, sheepish smile. Then he tilted his chin toward the door.

“That means you too, nerd,” Katsuki said.

Izuku frowned, the pout unmistakable as it formed on his lips. Katsuki had to hide his grin when Izuku let out an unhappy huff and turned around, clearly sour.

Once his footsteps faded, Aizawa raised an eyebrow from behind his coffee mug.

“So what’s with the secrecy?” he asked.

Katsuki cleared his throat, his face heating as he rubbed the back of his neck. He looked anywhere but at Aizawa.

“I want to propose to Izuku at the orchestra.”

Aizawa paused mid-sip. He lowered his mug slowly to study Katsuki with a strange expression.

“But you’re already married.”

“Yeah but it was by accident. And the officiant might’ve been a scam artist,” Katsuki muttered. He rubbed his face with a groan reliving that ordeal. “Look, it’s not about the legality. The nerd’s a romantic. I know he’s always dreamed of some fairytale proposal, and instead he got...a drunken ceremony in Okinawa that he was blacked out for with a ring that turns his finger green.”

Aizawa chuckled. “Charming.”

“I want to do it right,” Katsuki confessed. “Like, actually right this time. I want to surprise him and make it special.”

Aizawa leaned forward slightly. “So what do you need from me?”

“I need help getting a real ring. I don’t want to risk using my account with the Yakuza still looking for us, and I didn’t take out enough cash to afford anything decent. I’ll pay you back when we’re in the clear.”

“I’ll hold you to that,” Aizawa replied, smiling. “I don’t exactly want to use my own accounts right now. But luckily for you, I keep cash in the cabin. In case of a rainy day I stored away a lot of dollars. But I would be glad to use it on this.”

Katsuki exhaled, surprised at how grateful he felt. “You’re serious?”

“Dead serious,” Aizawa said. His tone was dry, but his eyes were warm. “Can’t say no to love, I guess.”

“I owe you.”

“You do. I’ll send you the bill when you least expect it.”

Katsuki snorted. His mind wandered as he excitedly thought about the proposal. He could perfectly picture how surprised Izuku would be. His nerd probably would cry out of joy and smile until his damn cheeks hurt.

While he was lost in his thoughts, Katsuki didn't notice he was grinning himself.

Aizawa did though. He smirked and said, "You really like him."

"A ton," Katsuki laughed. He shrugged, and though he tried to suppress it, his smile stretched wider. "I don't think I've ever liked someone this much—and much less had them like me back. It feels like I can tell him anything, even show him how goddamn fucked up I am, and he'll always smile and somehow love me more for it. It's more than I could ever ask for."

Aizawa didn't respond right away. He stared at him with eyes full of pride, relief, and a little bit of awe.

"There's a jewelry shop down in the town that can do rush orders," Aizawa said finally. He cleared his throat, as if brushing off the emotions he didn't want to show. "I can go today and see what he can do. Do you know what type of rings you want to buy?"

Katsuki grinned.

"Eternity rings."

☽ ☽ ☽

Within three days, Aizawa came through with the wedding rings. He pulled Katsuki aside in private, opened the velvet boxes, and revealed the contents.

Katsuki's grin stretched wide the moment he saw them. One eternity band was made entirely of emeralds, the other was made of rubies. And both were equally breathtaking. The stones gleamed with rich color that perfectly matched the hue of their eyes.

The moment he had them in hand, Katsuki wasted no time pulling everyone into his plan.

"Oh my god," Denki squealed, practically bouncing. "This is so awesome, dude! I call the decorations!"

"Yeah, I'll help!" Sero chimed in enthusiastically.

Katsuki was buzzing. This was going to be the best damn proposal imaginable. The nerd wouldn't know what hit him.

That night, when the cabin had gone quiet, Katsuki sat alone and turned the emerald ring over in his fingers. He didn't realize he was gently smiling as he stared at it, watching the way the light shimmered off the stones.

In each emerald, he could see him and Izuku together. In one he saw them as kids. In another he saw them throughout their teen years and then finally their reunion. Every emerald reflected back a memory doused in green like a storybook. And in one, Katsuki could see them old, together. They were sitting on the porch in chairs hand in hand.

Eternity looked damn beautiful.

☽ ☽ ☽

By the end of the week, everything was in place.

Denki and Sero stayed behind to decorate the cabin for the party. Shinsou did too, not particularly thrilled by Katsuki's idea for the proposal. But despite his lack of enthusiasm, he still pitched in. Katsuki was mildly surprised when Shinsou offered, without being asked, to bake the cake.

Miruko, Monoma, and Aizawa accompanied them down to the orchestra.

Monoma, of course, said he only wanted to come because he needed to see Katsuki get down on one knee. He claimed he didn't believe Katsuki could actually pull off a proper proposal. His tone was as snide as ever, but the jab carried no real meanness. If anything, it felt like he genuinely wanted to be there.

They descended the mountain in a questionable, rickety, cable car. It creaked with every sway and caught on the line in one violent snag that startled them all.

By the time they reached the base, Katsuki was relieved to be alive.

But even more so, he was relieved to see the venue looked as romantic as he'd hoped.

The concert hall stood like a glowing ember in the snow-covered town. Warm light flickered from tall, arched windows fogged with condensation. Golden light spilled into the pale afternoon, casting a glow that almost felt like music itself. Even from the outside, the sound of string instruments drifted into the air.

He scanned the small crowd. Most of them were elderly people, bundled in heavy coats and wool scarves.

They approached the ticket booth as a group. It was an old-fashioned stand trimmed in polished brass. The attendant handed them narrow slips of paper, simple white with delicate black lettering.

Katsuki paused to study his ticket. He read the name of the orchestra printed cleanly across the top.

"Fated Strings: The Twin Stars Concert Series"

Composer: Souta, Amane

They filed quietly into the auditorium, following the slow-moving crowd.

The room itself stole his breath. Rows of plush red velvet seats stretched in perfect symmetry. Each one was trimmed in gold that shimmered beneath the soft glow of the lights. The stage ahead was small and intimate. Its wooden floor was bare except for two simple chairs placed at its center. They were angled facing each other just so.

Katsuki and Izuku settled in the front row beside Aizawa, Miruko, and Monoma. All around them, the audience buzzed with a gentle excitement.

“They say the composer rose to fame only recently,” an older woman whispered from behind them. “Unusual for someone our age to break through now.”

“Definitely,” her companion replied. “But his music—it speaks like it’s been waiting to be heard all his life.”

Izuku glanced sideways at Katsuki, his eyes lighting with quiet curiosity. Katsuki caught the look and grinned. Without saying a word, he reached out and laced their fingers together.

Then, the house lights began to dim.

The low hum of conversation faded. The air thickened with anticipation, and a collective breath held tight.

In that quiet, Katsuki looked at Izuku—really looked.

The soft curve of his smile. The warmth in his big eyes. The calm that radiated from his presence. It hit Katsuki how lucky he was. Somehow, after all the tragedy and violence that riddled his life, he still got to sit here next to Izuku.

His husband caught him looking and smiled back.

The audience erupted into applause as a small woman walked briskly onto the stage. Her skin tone was similar to Miruko’s. And her brown eyes were large and expressive behind thick black glasses. Her dark hair was twisted neatly into a bun. She adjusted her blazer with practiced ease before gesturing warmly to the crowd.

“Hello everyone!” she announced, her voice echoing clearly through the auditorium. “I welcome you to the final act! Thank you all so much for sticking around. We have saved the very best performance for you. He is a new composer on the scene and his masterpiece has been sweeping the country. You all know him—Souta Amane.”

She stepped back and offered a low, graceful bow. “Please, give him a warm welcome!”

As she exited, two new women entered the stage.

Their presence was commanding. They both were dressed in elegant black ballroom gowns. One woman held a violin, and the other a viola. They took their seats in perfect silence, facing each other like reflections. A flicker of a smile passed between them.

Then, the man neither of them ever expected to see again stepped onto the stage.

Both Izuku and Katsuki froze. Their hands clenched tighter.

“Hello, music lovers,” Souta greeted warmly.

The audience erupted in applause and Katsuki’s jaw fell slack.

He stared, stunned.

It was him.

That same face was now lined with age but still alight with mischief and magic. The man's posture, presence, and voice was unmistakable. It was their quirky violinist. Holy shit.

The man walked with a limp now, and the curve of his spine had deepened. But he moved with purpose. His wild white hair was now combed neatly into a bun. Fresh, well-fitted clothes replaced the tattered layers of the past. And in his eyes, still, were stars.

Souta smiled delicately at the crowd. His gaze flitted across them like a breeze, never lingering too long in one place.

"I want to personally thank you all for coming out tonight," he said, his voice as smooth and whimsical as Katsuki remembered. "I know many of you have traveled far to come hear my humble concert pieces. And for that, I am more than thankful. I have composed a lovely hour-long session for you, about two twin stars falling from the sky in tandem. It's a love story, at its core. But it is also my vehicle to express my calling. And all I have ever wanted was to share my calling with the world."

He paused to take a deep breath. Then he straightened his back as much as his worn frame would allow.

"My calling is that I want to create something beautiful," he said—exactly as he had told them all those years ago. "Something that would never leave someone. I want it to imprint on their hearts and in their minds so whenever they hear this melody, they will remember where they were when they first heard it. They will smile, look towards the one they love, and be reminded of all the gorgeous reasons to live."

Beside him, Izuku exhaled shakily. Katsuki tightened his grip on his hand.

"Without further delay," Souta said with a familiar glimmer in his smile, "let us get started with the opening number."

He turned, suddenly solemn. His posture sharpened and his spine drew taut. With grace and precision, he raised his baton.

The violinist and violist lifted their instruments in unison.

Then the song began.

The Dance of The Love Birds wove through Katsuki's ears like wind through bare branches. The song brushed goosebumps across his skin. The melody moved with the softness of a river in spring. It was gentle but relentless, pulling him beneath its surface.

Without warning, he was carried backwards through the timeline of his life.

It began, as it always did, in the cold.

He saw himself surrounded by endless white. The brittle quiet of winter pressed in on all sides. Snow clung to his skin like judgment and gnawed at his bones as he froze alive in a world that offered no warmth. He chased flickers of heat. He even chased flashes of comfort that never stayed.

The tempo picked up. And with each measure of the viola, he felt his childhood unfold: cold shoulders, cruel silences, and the aching hunger for love. The frost bit into him deeper with every reminder that something in him was too broken to be held.

Then—a spark of warmth.

He saw the boy with pretty green eyes and a yellow plastic watch.

Izuku. Small, awkward, and smiling. He came into Katsuki's life like a walking ember. From behind his eyepatch spilled tenderness like sun through a half-drawn curtain. Katsuki watched as that love flooded the frozen corners of his world, melting snow drifts he thought were permanent.

He saw Izuku on a bench, shrugging off his own coat to give to him. Then he saw Izuku come back, day after day to make sure he was alright. And every time he visited with his radiant smile, came safety, kindness and heat.

As the melody softened, Katsuki saw the nook again. It was their perfect sanctuary. The warmth of it bled across his skin, soaking into his frostbitten soul. It whispered to the deepest, most damaged parts of him: You are worthy. You are not unwanted. You are not too broken.

Then the violin rose, brilliant and sure. He saw them dancing. Two small kids awkwardly swaying beneath the fractured wings of the stone angel. Stained glass poured color onto their skin and warmed them both.

The tempo spun them through time.

Then it slowed—and flung him forward.

He was older, alone again, and the cold had returned.

Snow blanketed everything. The only heat he had left was memory. He survived on dreams, rewinding time in his sleep just to touch the warmth once more. But the world had grown colder as he aged. It reminded him every day that he was too broken to be loved. His jagged edges were too sharp for anyone to ever want to get close. He assumed the warmth he'd once known was a fluke.

Until the music exploded.

The violin and viola collided, melting together into a fierce wave.

Every cold memory exploded into fever because Izuku had returned. He came back into his life like he had never left. He was older now, but just as warm—just as *loving*. Katsuki saw the years they spent orbiting one another. Their melodies were on parallel staves, always

edging closer to harmony. Their lives had been messy, broken, and bloodied—but they always circled back to one another.

Struggling. Searching. Surrendering.

And then—heat.

Katsuki saw them kiss. The music roared and the cold burned away. His brittle frostbite was replaced by a feverish passion. It consumed him whole. It was terrifying. Beautiful. *Alive*.

Katsuki turned to Izuku then.

His husband sat beside him, transfixed. His hands were tucked beneath his chin and his eyes were bright. Tears were sliding freely down his cheeks.

Katsuki's chest tightened.

Izuku had always seen him. Not as a monster or broken—but as a person worth loving. In every version of Izuku, in every year of knowing him, he had pushed Katsuki to be something the world never gave him permission to be: soft.

For the first time in his life, Katsuki saw the truth.

He wasn't broken. He wasn't cold by nature, he had merely been waiting to be thawed.

And Izuku was the one who had done it.

As the music swelled, Katsuki gave in. He let himself drown in the strings and in his memory. He gave himself over to the heat of what it meant to be truly, irreversibly loved.

☽ ☽ ☽

By the end of the concert, Katsuki and Izuku sat stunned in silence.

There were no words that could capture what had passed through them. The music, beginning with the melody that tied their lives together, felt like a rebirth.

It wasn't until thunderous applause erupted that the spell finally cracked. The audience rose around them like a tide, applauding with awe. Katsuki and Izuku stood too. Slowly, almost reluctant for the experience to end. They clapped not only with praise but with disbelief. Then they clapped faster in gratitude. Then finally, happiness.

Katsuki wiped a tear from his cheek and huffed out a quiet, shaking laugh.

The man who had once been a drifting street violinist was now transformed. He was a maestro of feeling, story, and sound. It made Katsuki's chest ache with joy.

He had thought of the violinist often, even if fleetingly. He'd been the reason Katsuki dreamed of music at all. He'd shown Katsuki that beauty could still come out of pain. That no matter how dark the road, somehow, brightness could still come from it.

Souta stood under the lights, smiling wide as roses fell from the balconies.

Katsuki cursed himself for not bringing any. Instead, he cheered until his throat went raw and clapped until his palms burned. On stage, Souta bowed deeply alongside the violinist and violist. The three of them smiled and waved until the crimson curtains swept shut.

Katsuki let out a breathy laugh and wiped it away with the back of his hand. He turned toward Izuku, heart full.

“That was the best thing I’ve ever fucking seen,” he said, voice cracked with emotion.

Izuku gave a watery laugh. “Yeah,” he breathed, dabbing at his cheeks with little success.

Katsuki reached out and gently brushed away the dampness clinging to Izuku’s face. For a moment they stood there, smiling like fools in the afterglow. Then Katsuki’s expression shifted. His brows knitted, eyes flicking toward the curtain.

“We have to go find him,” he said suddenly.

Izuku nodded without hesitation, and their hands found each other.

Together, they turned to the rest of their group. In urgent voices, they explained that the composer meant a lot from their past in Tokyo. Aizawa, Miruko, and Monoma didn’t ask many questions. They simply nodded and followed. They weaved through the crowd, Izuku at the front, Katsuki close behind.

When they reached the lobby, it wasn’t hard to find him.

Souta stood beneath the statue of a golden angel, bathed in warm light. A group of older women surrounded him. They all offered flowers and laughter as he bashfully rocked on his heels. He grinned at them with the same mischief and gentleness that had once lit the streets of Tokyo.

Katsuki and Izuku exchanged a glance.

Their fingers tightened together. And when the group began to thin out, they stepped forward.

Souta turned to them. In his eyes was the same quiet magic that had followed them all their lives.

“Hello there!” he said brightly. “Did you enjoy the show?”

“We did,” Katsuki replied, voice stiff at first. “We more than enjoyed it, actually.”

“We—” Izuku began, then paused. He swallowed and started again. “We wanted to ask you something. If that’s alright.”

“Of course,” Souta replied, warm as ever. “Ask me anything.”

They both shifted awkwardly, nerves tying their tongues in knots. Their silence dragged a beat too long, like they were trying to step forwards and backwards at the same time. Somewhere behind them, Aizawa let out the faintest sigh. Katsuki winced.

He hadn't felt like a kid in years. And yet here they were again, two small, uncertain boys at the edge of the world.

"I'm Katsuki," he finally said, voice a little steadier now. "And this is Izuku. We used to hang around you a lot. In San'ya, Tokyo. About eighteen years ago?"

Souta's smile faltered.

His brows slowly knitted together, and Katsuki leaned in a little. He watched the realization unfold across the man's face. Souta's gaze moved to their hair, eyes, and finally, their interlocked hands.

"We were there," Katsuki added quietly, "when you first started refining your opening song."

Souta gasped. His hands rose instinctively and hovered midair like he wasn't sure what to do. Then his face bloomed with wonder.

"Oh my goodness," Souta whispered. "It's you! My little ones!"

His gaze flicked between them, eyes going wide with disbelief. Then he blinked, taking in their adult frames, and let out a soft laugh.

"Or—well, not so little anymore. Either of you," Souta chuckled. A delicate grin stretched across his face.

Izuku let out a light laugh. Katsuki followed, unable to stop the smile curling at his lips.

"This is incredible," Souta sang happily, clasping his hands together. He stepped closer, eyes gleaming with warmth. Without hesitation, he opened his arms wide. "Well? What are you standing there for? Come give me a hug!"

They didn't need to be told twice.

Izuku and Katsuki moved in at once with tearful smiles. Souta's bony arms wrapped around them with surprising strength, and Katsuki leaned into the embrace. His arms clung tighter to the man who had unknowingly stitched music and Izuku into the very fabric of his soul.

He smiled wider, holding on as if he could make the moment last forever.

When Souta finally pulled back, he took his time studying them. He nodded in approval and grinned, showing the same crooked teeth. Still a few were missing, but now it was obvious he had a toothbrush.

"I can't believe this," Souta murmured. His gaze dropped to their intertwined hands, and pride spread across his face. "You've been reunited. All my life, I thought you two were separated for good after you disappeared. But you're here. Together."

Katsuki wiped his face with the back of his hand and laughed dryly. “What are the chances, huh?”

Souta wagged a finger. “There’s no such thing as chances, little one. It’s always fate.”

Fate.

Katsuki broke out into a hopeful smile.

Of course it had been fate. How had he been so damn blind all his life?

“I’m so happy to see you’re doing well,” Izuku said softly, stepping back as the embrace loosened. “I thought about you a lot, after everything. I was worried something bad happened.”

Souta’s expression turned tender.

“I was able to get my life together again because of you both,” he said. “When you stopped coming around, it was… hard. I didn’t realize how much I leaned on you. Your presence, your ears, your belief in me—it was like medicine. You helped me grieve my wife. You were the best audience I’ve ever—no.” He corrected himself with a soft shake of the head. “You are the best audience I’ll ever have.”

He turned to Izuku then, gratitude shining in his warm brown eyes.

“And that money you gave me?” Souta said. “I used it to get a room in a small hotel. Something stable. It gave me time to breathe, to think, to pull myself back together.”

“I’m glad it helped,” Izuku replied gently.

“There aren’t enough ‘thank yous’ in the world for it,” Souta whispered. “After that, I got clean. Started playing again. The song finally felt finished. And secretly, I hoped that if I played it long enough, loud enough, it would bring you two back to each other. Just like it did the first time.”

“You were right,” Katsuki chuckled. “We were—just in a roundabout way.”

Izuku smiled. “Adding the viola was a perfect touch. I always thought that song was a solo.”

Souta’s eyes twinkled.

“It was always a duet,” he said with a playful wink. “It was never meant to be played alone.”

Katsuki and Izuku exchanged soft, knowing looks.

“Enough about me!” Souta announced suddenly, alive with energy. He clapped his hands and brought them to his chest. “Tell me—how have the two of you been?”

Katsuki almost said, *fucking terrible*—but stopped himself. Because right now, everything was okay. Izuku was by his side. They had found each other again. And now even Souta, this

unexpected anchor from their past, had come back into their lives.

For the first time, it felt like they were moving forward. Healing, even.

Katsuki shrugged. “We’ve—We’ve been great.”

“Yeah,” Izuku agreed weakly.

Souta beamed. He turned eagerly to Katsuki, eyes gleaming.

“Please tell me you grew up to be a composer!” he exclaimed. “Your ear for harmony and timing—it’s like listening to a clockmaker fine-tuning the gears of a symphony. I couldn’t have pulled off that piece without you.”

Then he turned to Izuku, warmth deepening in his voice. “And you! I’ve never seen anyone take to the violin the way you did that year. You played like someone who’d stumbled upon a buried part of his soul and was aching to let it sing! Surely, you both stayed in music?”

Katsuki saw Izuku’s shoulders slump.

The lights in his eye flickered off for a moment, clearly affected.

Without missing a beat, Katsuki wrapped an arm around Izuku. He lovingly squeezed his shoulder.

“We’re working on it,” Katsuki declared confidently. He turned to Izuku then and offered up a strong, hopeful smile that said, ‘*we will get there*’.

Izuku nodded back and he leaned into him.

“We’re actually leaving Japan soon for a, uh, fresh start. You could say,” Katsuki continued. “But we’re both really damn happy we got the chance to see you again before we headed out.”

Souta perked up. “You’re leaving together?” He glanced between them. “Like you meant to before?”

“Yeah,” Katsuki replied. “We are.”

They fixed each other with gentle gazes. A piece of Katsuki gradually softened. He stared, lost in those beautiful green eyes. Somehow, those eyes were somehow the answers to all of his worries in life. His heart rate increased. The longer he studied Izuku, the more it felt as if fate was surrounding them.

Truly, how could he ever ask for a better moment to propose?

He licked his lips and cleared his throat.

“Actually,” Katsuki said. He shifted his stance, squaring his body towards Izuku, bracing himself to do something he never thought he would ever do. “There was something I wanted

to do tonight. I was going to wait until later but—I can't think of a better time than to do it now."

His arm slowly slipped from Izuku, breaking their hold with deliberate care. He cleared his throat again out of jitters.

Izuku's brow pinched. "Kacchan?"

Katsuki took a step back.

His movements were taut with purpose. He gazed Izuku dead in the eyes and all he could see was them together in that future countryside. He reached in his coat pocket with full confidence and burning resolve.

The crowd and world amplified as he felt every emotion rush towards him in a stampede. He felt love. He felt joy. Affection. Happiness. *Relief*. And above all of it, he felt that unshakable pull of destiny—a red string from his heart to Izuku's.

Katsuki dropped to one knee.

The moment unfolded in total clarity.

The soft hitch of Izuku's breath. The way his damn gorgeous eyes went wide when Katsuki flicked open the velvet box. The way the warm glow of the chandelier brightened the hue of the moment. The sound of everyone around them gasping and cheering them on was like a melody keeping rhythm to the beat of his heart.

"Bakugou Izuku," Katsuki said, his voice cracking around the edges. He pushed the ring up and tethered Izuku's gaze. "Will you marry me?"

For a heartbeat, Izuku could only blink. His mouth parted in shock.

"Wh-What—" Izuku stammered. His cheeks bloomed with color. "We're already married—"

"—Marry me again," Katsuki insisted. His grip on the ring box tightened. "*Sober* this time."

His gaze didn't waver. He burned from the inside out with passion and conviction for Izuku. But behind all that fire was a vulnerability he usually never let anyone see. Progressively, piece by piece, Katsuki unraveled himself. He shed his defenses, tucked away every instinct to flinch, to guard, and to hide. He offered up the barest parts of himself to be seen.

He showed everyone around them the aching, gaping wound he'd never dared let be exposed —all for Izuku.

Without a word, Izuku dropped to his knees. He reached out to cup Katsuki's face and nodded.

"*Yes*," Izuku choked out. "Yes, of course, I'll marry you again."

Laughter burst from him through the sobs, the sound was shaky and radiant. Soon Katsuki laughed too, overcome by emotion. It felt like his broken heart inside him was mending again, pulled together by the strength of Izuku's love.

They grinned like fools, two lovers who had braved many storms and finally found harbor within each other.

Katsuki took Izuku's hand. With care, he slipped off the old, rusted ring and tucked it safely into Izuku's pocket. Then, with a triumphant grin stretched across his face, he slid the new wedding ring of rubies into place.

It fit like it had always belonged there.

The crowd erupted into applause.

Katsuki's heart soared so high it felt like it might fly away. He glanced up to see Miruko whistling and clapping with wild enthusiasm. Aizawa stood with his arms folded and a rare look of quiet pride. Even Monoma rolled his eyes. But not even he could hide the crooked smile tugging at his mouth.

All around them, guests began to join in. Cheers echoed through the golden-lit lobby. The sound swelled to an applause that matched the one Souta got.

And in the center of it all, Katsuki and Izuku knelt together.

Souta was crying now too, clapping his frail hands. His face was alight with joy. He laughed exactly like he used to, raspy and full of warmth.

"My little ones," Souta murmured through trembling lips. "My fated little ones."

Then, with care, Souta bent down and lifted the violin case at his feet. A quiet click echoed as he opened it, revealing a gleaming white violin nestled inside. He drew it out and cradled the instrument like it was his only possession.

With one fluid motion, he raised the bow and set his stance.

The three of them exchanged a single look. And for a fleeting moment, Katsuki felt as though he'd stepped into Izuku's book.

"Let me offer you a dance," Souta said gently, his voice threaded with joy. "To celebrate your real marriage."

He didn't wait for a reply. He simply began to play.

The Dance of the Love Birds unfurled like silk in the air. But this time, it sounded even richer, even more alive.

Katsuki reached out and tugged Izuku to his feet. Dazed but smiling, Izuku followed.

They stumbled a little at first, bumping into each other with breathless laughter. Then, as always, they found their rhythm. Their push and pull. Their chase and catch. They twirled and stepped, swayed and turned. And they let the music guide them like it had all those years ago in Tokyo.

The song wrapped around them like a ribbon of nostalgia, binding them beneath the golden angel.

They never looked away from each other.

When the final note rang out, applause blossomed again. This time it was softer. Murmurs and sniffles wove through the air. A few scattered whistles broke the hush, but even those felt weighted with emotion.

Izuku gazed up at him with stars in his eyes.

And for once, it felt like the universe had aligned.

Katsuki pulled his husband into him, arms wrapped tight. Izuku held him back, matching the strength. It was a fierce hold that said *I love you* in more ways than there were languages.

“Sorry for the ambush,” Katsuki murmured against Izuku’s ear. “I wanted it to be a surprise. Y’know, romantic and all.”

Izuku smiled into his chest.

“It was,” he whispered. “Well done.”

Katsuki swelled with pride for making his husband happy.

☽ ☽ ☽

When they returned to the cabin, the celebration that followed felt like it could’ve lasted a hundred nights. It was, without question, the most unforgettable evening of Katsuki’s life. Despite the tacky decorations it was somehow more beautiful than anything he could have asked for.

Izuku couldn’t stop staring at his ring. His cheeks tinted pink and his lips curled into that radiant smile Katsuki always loved. He looked happy in the way Katsuki always hoped he could one day make him.

And being surrounded by their chaotic, beloved crew made it all the more perfect. Just as the room had quieted from the initial cheers, Katsuki revealed the second ring.

A emerald eternity band meant to mirror Izuku’s.

Izuku’s eyes widened, and with slightly trembling fingers, he slid it onto Katsuki’s hand.

It clicked into place like it had always belonged there.

Joy flooded Katsuki's chest. It was almost overwhelming. He hadn't known happiness could feel this full. He felt somehow both wild and tamed. But above all, complete.

The rest of the night unfolded in an ecstatic blur. They danced. They drank too much. They sang off-key and off-tempo. All of their laughter rose into the rafters like firelight. The world beyond the cabin might as well have vanished; nothing existed except this moment.

And when things finally calmed down, Katsuki wasn't ready for it to end.

One by one, their friends stumbled off to bed. They were all too drunk or too sleepy to keep their eyes open. Doors clicked shut down the hallway, and the two of them were alone on the couch. They were tangled together and giggling. Their cheeks were flushed and they both were very much tipsy.

Izuku was still gazing at his hand like it held the galaxy.

They sat like that for a while, shoulders pressed and limbs overlapping.

"What color suits should we wear at our wedding?" Izuku asked, voice soft.

"White or black," Katsuki answered without missing a beat. "Maybe you in white. You'd look—" he hesitated, almost shy, "—fucking beautiful."

Izuku grinned. "I think we should both have pink suits."

Katsuki barked out a laugh. His eyes narrowed in mock horror as the image invaded his mind.

"Not a chance," he chuckled. "It'll be a long day in hell before I ever wear a pink suit."

"Never say never, Kacchan," Izuku sing-songed.

They laughed together, warmth radiating in every direction.

They stayed there, curled together on the couch. They talked into the quiet of the night, debating wedding decorations and clothes. They lightly bickered about table runners and flower arrangements. They also joked about a cake made of katsudon.

Katsuki never thought he'd be arguing over what songs to play for a first dance, but here they were. He played fake appalled at all the cheesy songs Izuku suggested. But really, he loved them all. He'd dance with Izuku to any song as long as his husband was the one he was dancing with.

At some point, Katsuki's eyes drifted closed, lulled by the calm and the comfort of the body against his.

Izuku followed soon after, their breaths slowing in sync.

And eventually, in the softest kind of peace, they both fell asleep in each other's arms.

☽ ☽ ☽

The next three days passed with a quiet, growing kinship in the cabin.

Conversations flowed more easily. Laughter lingered a little longer.

Even Shinsou, who had wielded his suspicion like a sword, began to soften at the edges. His replies lost their bite, and he no longer looked at Izuku like a ticking bomb. Which was great because Katsuki wanted them to be on good terms when they inevitably departed—which was coming soon.

They were officially less than a week away from leaving with Nana.

Katsuki couldn't believe it.

No. Really.

He couldn't believe it.

While the others relaxed, Katsuki went the opposite direction entirely. After the proposal, there was no doubt left in his mind—being together with Izuku was his fate. And that certainty made everything feel more dangerous. Because now Katsuki fully understood how much he had to lose. The thought of being separated from Izuku, gnawed at him day and night.

And their current situation felt too easy.

If there was one thing Katsuki had learned from Izuku's horror stories, it was that *easy* was never a word that described Tomura. That bastard played the long game. He sets traps within traps, always with a contingency plan waiting underneath. He was a cunning, calculating master strategist who saw the board ten moves ahead.

Katsuki had witnessed that firsthand when he discovered the tracker buried in his bike. And he knew—deep in his goddamn bones—that something was off. Because monsters recognized monsters. And Tomura wasn't just any monster—he was an apex predator.

Which begged the question, why had nothing occurred the last few weeks?

He knew better than to underestimate the Yakuza or the Vipers. And the longer this fragile peace held, the more it set him on edge. Which is why when Aizawa began to discuss their escape route, his gut was screaming bloody murder.

"Alright, everyone," Aizawa said. He gathered them at the large dining room table with notes and a map. "We're going to begin our journey to Okinawa soon."

He dragged his finger to the point where Nana would be located and circled it in red marker.

Aizawa continued on, "I have sent word to a friend and he's bringing my private boat up to the north point of Mount Rausu. It should be smooth sailing. The ship is discreet enough that we'll be able to ease by without alerting any Yakuza."

“How long will we be on the boat?” Izuku asked seriously.

“About three days,” Aizawa informed them. “Which means, we need to leave from here in two days. After this, everyone needs to start packing their bags and preparing their weapons. Please leave the bags in the bunker area in case of an emergency exit.”

No one argued.

One by one, they packed their things in tense silence, quietly storing bags in the bunker beneath the cabin. Once the preparations were done, the house fell into a hush, broken only by the wind brushing against the windows and the soft crackle of the fire.

By the time the last light flicked off, Katsuki and Izuku were in bed. Katsuki laid on his back. One of his arms was around Izuku’s shoulders and his fingers absently traced circles on his bare skin. He stared into the darkness, eyes fixed on the opposite wall.

Izuku was curled into his side. His head rested over Katsuki’s chest, utterly content.

“Wow, we’re so close,” Izuku whispered with a sleepy grin. “Can you believe it?”

Not really, Katsuki wanted to say. But instead, he murmured, “Yeah. We are.”

Izuku cracked one eye open and tilted his head. “Aw, c’mon. Add some enthusiasm in there.” His grin widened. “It’s a miracle nothing’s happened so far. Smile a bit.”

Katsuki offered a fake, crooked grin. “You’re right. It’s a miracle.”

“I’m gonna dream of us on the boat,” Izuku mumbled, already halfway to sleep.

Katsuki leaned in and kissed his forehead. “You do that.”

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki couldn’t fucking sleep.

The hours dragged on, ticking by like the countdown to a bomb. Each minute was louder in his skull than the last. The clock read almost midnight, and he hadn’t caught a single wink of sleep. Why? Because his cursed, relentless paranoia had clawed its way back in his head. It was whispering poison straight into his skull.

But this time, it wasn’t about him.

It was about Izuku.

“You’re not strong enough to keep him safe,” hissed his self hatred. “He’s going to be taken from you, and you won’t be able to stop it.”

“Even if you were strong enough,” added self-doubt, quieter but crueler, “what if you’re not prepared for the Vipers? What if they take everything?”

Then came the worst of it—

“What if you’re not smart enough to outmaneuver Tomura?” His anxiety slithered in. “He could show up tomorrow and snatch Izuku from your arms. And you’d just have to watch it happen.”

That was the thought that did it.

Katsuki bolted upright, heart racing and breath uneven. Sweat pricked along his hairline. He reached over and shook Izuku, urgent and sharp.

“Izuku. Wake up.”

Izuku groaned sleepily, voice gravel-thick and confused. “Huh…? Kacchan?”

“We need to put a tracker on you,” Katsuki announced without preamble. “*Now*. In case we get separated. I—I have a bad feeling. And I’m not taking chances with your brother involved. Frankly, we should have done this a while ago given the situation.”

Izuku blinked blearily, his eyes barely open. “...I don’t have a cracker,” he mumbled.

Katsuki frowned. “What?”

“I said—no more cracker talk, Kacchan,” Izuku slurred, eyes drifting shut again. “We can get more crackers when the boat docks.”

“What the fuck,” Katsuki muttered.

He gaped as Izuku flopped back onto the pillow and curled up like nothing happened.

Then Katsuki tried shaking his husband again. “Izuku.”

But he was already gone, lips parted in sleep, breath gently even. He mumbled something that sounded vaguely like ‘cabin cheese’. He swatted lazily at Katsuki like he was an annoying fly.

Katsuki exhaled hard. He dragged both hands down his face. “Fuck me.”

He sat back, grinding the heels of his palms into his eyes. He tried to force the intrusive thoughts into silence. But they didn’t fade—they multiplied.

The longer he sat there, the louder the inner noise became, a chorus of worst-case scenarios. He saw every single one. And in every story line, he wasn’t crafty enough to get the upper hand on Tomura. Because that bastard’s sharpest weapon wasn’t his physical strength, it was his mind.

Katsuki glanced toward the bag by the wall. It was the one that held all his tracking gear.

Then he glanced down at Izuku’s hand. His ruby wedding ring glinted in the moonlight.

Katsuki's stomach turned.

An idea was forming. It was birthed from a lifetime of sheer survival instinct. He hesitated, heart pounding with an inkling of guilt. The better half of him told him to wait until the morning to discuss it with Izuku—but the side of him that was controlled by his insecurities was louder.

Fuck it.

Cynicism is what kept him alive this long. Because while he might've started to believe in fate lately, he sure as fuck didn't believe in miracles.

With a steady, practiced hand, Katsuki slid the ring from Izuku's finger.

He got out of bed and moved toward his gear.

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki sat hunched over the kitchen table. The only light in the dark cabin came from a single overhead bulb casting a harsh yellow circle over his work.

Scattered across the wooden surface were thin wires, globs of adhesive, and the tiniest tracking chip he'd ever tried to use. It was about the size of a small, unremarkable beed. His magnifying glasses sat perched on the bridge of his nose as he held fine-tipped tweezers. He was carefully attempting to wedge the tracker between the rubies of Izuku's wedding ring.

It wasn't going well.

The glue he had wasn't meant for metal, and the tracker kept slipping.

But Katsuki was stubborn. He'd make it work, even if it took all night.

Just when he thought he found the right angle, a deliberate throat-clearing snapped him out of his tunnel vision. Katsuki's head jerked up.

Standing in the hallway was Monoma. The other blond was dead-eyed and draped in a royal blue robe with fuzzy purple slippers. And on his face was the most unimpressed expression, looking like a true judgmental king.

"What are you doing?" Monoma asked flatly, arms crossed and an eyebrow arched.

Katsuki yanked off his glasses and put down the ring. "Nothing."

Monoma cocked his head. "That doesn't look like nothing."

Scowling, Katsuki crossed his arms over his chest. "What are you doing up?"

"I came for a drink of water," Monoma quipped back. "The air up here dries out my throat. I have delicate vocal cords and I want to make sure they're not damaged for future karaoke sessions."

“Then get your water and go back to bed,” Katsuki snapped.

But Monoma, ever the pain in his ass, took his sweet time. He shuffled to the fridge, opened it with a sigh, and let the fluorescent light spill out. He retrieved a glass with exaggerated slowness, filled it with water, and drank it like he was a goddamn fish.

Just when Katsuki thought he was finally done, he was proven wrong.

Monoma wandered over and took a seat across from him at the table. He looked at the mess with scrutinizing eyes. Then he reached for Izuku’s ring and held it up between two fingers.

“You’re not seriously putting a *tracker* in your husband’s wedding band, are you?”

Katsuki pressed his lips together, jaw ticking.

They glared each other down, like two bulldogs locked in a dead stare. Katsuki hated how easily Monoma could read him. And the feeling was likely returned tenfold.

Finally, he broke.

“Yeah. I am,” Katsuki confessed.

Monoma didn’t react.

No scoff. No judgment. Only silence, and his eyes remained fixed on the ring.

Katsuki sighed, rubbing the back of his neck. His voice dropped low, barely above a whisper.

“I couldn’t sleep,” he admitted. “I kept thinking...if something happens—I need a way to find him.” His fingers hovered over the tracker again, trembling slightly. “This is the only thing I could think of.”

For a long beat, Monoma said nothing. Then, finally, he set the ring down on the table. He gave Katsuki a look that was uncharacteristically tender, and leaned back in his chair.

“Are you going to tell him?” Monoma asked.

Katsuki huffed. “Yeah, I’m gonna tell him,” he muttered, more defensive than he meant to be. “First thing in the morning. I just…couldn’t sleep with the idea bouncing around in my head. I had to do something.”

Monoma tilted his head, studying him. “Honestly, I’m surprised you two didn’t discuss tagging him already. Considering how high stakes the situation is.”

Katsuki exhaled hard through his nose. “Yeah. I know, I should’ve. I’m stupid.”

“Not stupid,” Monoma offered. “Simply overconfident. Like most barbarians.”

Katsuki shot him a look. “Takes one to know one.”

Monoma chuckled and his eyes dropped to the mess spread across the table. A pensive minute passed.

“Well,” he said, voice quieter now. “Then let’s make sure it doesn’t fall off when he runs for his life.”

Katsuki blinked. “…You’re helping?”

“Of course I’m helping,” Monoma snipped. “You think I’d let all this work go to waste just because your glue sucks?”

Katsuki huffed a quiet, exhausted laugh. “Thanks.”

“Don’t thank me yet,” Monoma said. “You still owe me a real drink when this shit show is over.”

“Yeah,” Katsuki agreed softly. “Deal.”

“That glue’s not going to hold on to metal,” Monoma added, voice flat. “You need to weld it. Sero left his repair kit under the sink after fixing that busted pipe.”

Without waiting for a response, he shuffled over to the cabinets. He crouched and pulled out a small black toolkit. He tossed it gently onto the table in front of Katsuki.

“There’s a mini soldering iron in there,” Monoma informed him. He walked back to the chair and flopped down with a sigh. He kicked his feet up onto a nearby stool. “That’ll hold better than any glue.”

Katsuki muttered a quick “thanks” and opened the kit. He plugged in the soldering iron to warm it up.

While they waited, Monoma tapped a finger against the table.

“So…why the wedding band?” he asked, curious now. “Why not sew the tracker into his coat or boot or something less sentimental?”

“Because clothes get tossed,” Katsuki answered without hesitation. “This wedding ring is the one thing I know Izuku will keep until the bitter end.”

Monoma considered that, then asked, “But what if the Chisakis or his crazy brother throw it away if they capture him?”

Katsuki hesitated. His jaw worked, eyes narrowing in thought. “Chisaki might strip him of it, yeah. But Tomura…” He trailed off, then wet his lips and leaned forward, elbows on the table. “I don’t think he would.”

Monoma frowned. “You think that psycho would let him keep the ring? Really?”

“I do,” Katsuki muttered seriously.

“What makes you think that?”

“We had an interaction. And it’s been making me think long and hard.”

“When the hell did you have an encounter with him?” Monoma hissed.

“I…I haven’t told Izuku yet, but directly after that masquerade, Tomura found me,” Katsuki regretfully admitted. “I didn’t know who he was. He introduced himself under an alias. But he proposed this stupid fucking deal to me. He asked me to bring him Izuku in exchange for letting me kill Chisaki.”

Monoma’s expression darkened. “Did you take it?”

“Not at first,” Katsuki hesitated, the shame surfacing hard and fast. He looked away. “I told him I was going to kill Izuku. But for some reason, even *after* I declared that, he gave me the information to go track Izuku down.”

“…Strange,” Monoma murmured. His voice was tight, calculating.

“Right? It was fucking weird,” Katsuki agreed, meeting his eyes now. “But when I realized I didn’t want to kill Izuku. I…I took the deal.”

A long, tired sigh passed through Monoma. He pinched the bridge of his nose and shook his head.

“Bakugou…”

“I know.” Katsuki grimaced. “I thought giving him back would be bringing him to this super comfortable life. All I saw was the shiny watches and name brands he was dressed in. Things I could never even dream of affording all my life. I thought giving him back wouldn’t be that bad—” He choked up, and clenched his teeth. “And after he told me everything, I was so fucking *wrong*. I realized who Tomura was and I—I panicked. I panicked all the way to this fucking cabin.”

Nothing happened for a long moment.

Monoma didn’t speak. He stared, his face unreadable.

Katsuki let out a hollow laugh, trying to mask the guilt curling in his gut. “Well? Aren’t you gonna rip into me? Call me a lunatic?”

But Monoma shook his head slowly.

“No,” he said. “If it were me in your shoes, I probably would’ve done the same thing.”

Katsuki blinked, caught off guard.

Monoma gave a small, tired shrug. “We’re not saints, Bakugou. We’re only humans trying to survive the fallout of our own damage. The fact you’re here now, protecting him after getting

the whole picture, says more than whatever bullshit deal you made when you were blinded by hurt."

"…Thanks," Katsuki said, a touch surprised.

"But what does any of that have to do with thinking Tomura won't toss the ring?"

Katsuki took a deep breath, gathering the words. He leaned forward, elbows on the table, hands folded in front of his mouth.

"I keep thinking about him giving me that information," he murmured. "It makes no tactical sense—unless he already knew what I'd do with it."

Monoma's eyes narrowed thoughtfully. "You mean he predicted you wouldn't go through with killing Izuku."

"Exactly," Katsuki said, sharp now. "He handed me a loaded gun and bet on me not pulling the trigger. And the only way you can predict someone's move that precisely is if you know yourself what choice you'd make."

Monoma tilted his head. "Because it's the choice you'd make in their place."

Katsuki huffed out a grim laugh. "Bingo. That's how projection works. You see someone's path so clearly because it's your own. You pretend you're reading them when really you're just looking in a mirror."

Monoma slowly nodded, the pieces beginning to click. "So you think Tomura saw something of himself in you."

"Not in personality," Katsuki clarified. "We're nothing alike on that front. But our loyalty to Izuku? That's where we align. As twisted as it is, I think he's just as fucking devoted."

That gave Monoma pause.

His eyebrows lifted slightly, and he looked away for a second before quietly nodding in agreement.

Katsuki continued, his voice a little quieter now. "From what Izuku's told me…Tomura thinks he's protecting him. He's got this warped, sadistic big brother complex. He believes the pain he inflicts is justified because of how they grew up. He basically thinks breaking Izuku down somehow makes him safer. Stronger. *Better*."

He ran a hand through his hair, eyes heavy with the weight of understanding.

"But Tomura has weak points," Katsuki whispered. "There's these cracks that show up when Izuku's at rock bottom. It's like, no matter how damn cruel Tomura is, he still can't *fully* stomach watching Izuku suffer. He can't help but try to coddle him."

"And that," Monoma murmured, "is why you think he wouldn't throw away the ring."

Katsuki nodded. “If Tomura separates me and Izuku, Izuku will be devastated. Like *really* fucking devastated. And I know Izuku well enough that he’s going to cling to his damn ring like it’s oxygen. And if Tomura tries to take it—Izuku will break down. And when Izuku breaks down, Tomura’s weak point is activated.”

“…Ah,” Monoma hummed. “Makes sense. You’re gambling on him letting Izuku keep the ring like he gambled on you not being able to kill him.”

“I’m not gambling,” Katsuki shot back. “I know he will.”

Monoma’s brows lifted. “Do you have any proof that Tomura’s got a soft spot?”

Katsuki didn’t hesitate. “He let Izuku stay with me for a whole month after finding out about us. Realistically, he should’ve dragged him back to Tokyo that same night. But he didn’t. And get this—he built Izuku a fucking library full of romance novels. Books that are completely banned for them. It’s considered forbidden literature. But Tomura gave it to Izuku anyway.”

Monoma let out a low whistle. “Damn.”

“The list doesn’t stop there,” Katsuki muttered. “Izuku told me enough little moments that make it obvious. Tomura’s weakness is Izuku. And somehow, he knew Izuku was mine too. But I don’t get *how*. He threatened him into silence about my mom, like he really believed I’d kill him if I found out. But then, just like that, he hands me the key to find him? What the hell made him switch?”

“He probably figured it out after the masquerade.”

Katsuki blinked. “What makes you say that?”

“C’mon,” Monoma scoffed. He rolled his eyes. “You wiped out sixty Yakuza, but *magically* Izuku walked away breathing? You’re a lot of things, but inaccurate isn’t one. Aizawa would’ve never hired you if you couldn’t shoot straight.”

Katsuki drummed his fingers against his lips, brows drawn in deep thought.

“You think he pieced that together?” Katsuki asked.

“If I can put that together, then someone nicknamed the fucking *Horned Viper*, definitely can,” Monoma deadpanned. “He probably saw those bodies, and knowing you, they all were killed with a clean single bullet. Then he saw how you magically missed Izuku. The math is pretty easy. After the masquerade, he realized he was wrong.”

The two of them sat in silence for a long moment.

The weight of the conversation lingered in the air like smoke.

Katsuki assessed Monoma’s words over in his head, dissecting each one.

As much as he hated to admit it, Monoma was right. It was impressive and terrifying that Tomura might’ve managed to connect the dots. Even more impressive that he adjusted his

strategy accordingly. If Katsuki ever wanted a shot at staying one step ahead of him, he'd have to start thinking like a serpent too.

A sharp beep cut through the quiet.

The soldering tool was ready.

Katsuki stood, retrieved it, and returned to the table. Without a word, Monoma slipped on the spare pair of heat-resistant gloves and helped him get to work. They didn't speak. They simply moved, fully synchronized like old pros who'd worked side by side for over a decade.

Katsuki used the fine-tipped tool to carve a tiny groove inside the band.

He placed the crumb sized tracker into the hollow, then carefully layered melted metal over it. He sealed it solidly into the silver. When it was cool enough, he picked up a mini-sander from the toolbox and buffed it smooth. It wasn't flawless, but it would pass any glance.

No one would see it unless they were looking for it.

And no one would ever be looking.

When it was done, he and Monoma exchanged a silent glance of mutual understanding.

"You should tell Izuku about the deal tomorrow," Monoma advised quietly. "Maybe at the same time you tell him about the tracker."

Katsuki exhaled slowly through his nose.

"I know you're scared it'll hurt him," Monoma added gently, "but you have to tell him. He deserves that. And I think…I think he'll understand. Just like he will about this."

Katsuki clicked his tongue and looked away, conflicted. For days now, things have felt easier. The glow of the proposal still hung in the air, and Izuku had finally relaxed. It was clear Izuku let himself believe they were safe.

But Monoma was right.

"Yeah," Katsuki muttered. "I'll tell him tomorrow after breakfast."

Monoma nodded, satisfied. He pushed his chair back and tucked his hands into his robe pockets.

"Goodnight, Bakugou. Try not to let the world end while I'm asleep."

Katsuki snorted. "No promises."

With a tired grunt, Monoma disappeared down the dark hallway. Katsuki began to clean up the mess. He packed away all the tools, wires, and polish.

In the end, he picked up the finished ring. He held it under the pendant light. Carefully, he turned it slowly between his fingers. The embedded rubies shimmered faintly, catching glints of silver and red under the low light.

A grin tugged at the corner of his mouth.

“Checkmate, Tomura.”

Chapter End Notes

Let me know what you think below!!!<3 <3 Thank you so much again!! I'm so stoked for the next chapter :'D

Chapter 42: Riprendendo

Chapter Summary

> Riprendendo (indicator) — A tempo marker that tells the performer to resume the tempo that was in place before a change

Chapter Notes

> Surprise!! :^D Double update this week because happy pride month 💕💕! I get extra super powers during this month. 🥳 Whoohooo!!! This chapter is the full lap into the present timeline, no a better way to close out pride 🙏🏾
>
> Big thank you to the LOML, Luna for betaing like always!! 💜💜💜 I'll get around to comments soon :^) I just couldn't really wait to post this one and I know you all have been eager for the last month to find out what occurred.
>
> Also if you want, please take a special listen to the songs in this chapter! I've been very excitedly holding on to these ones for this specific chapter.
>
> Without further delay, please enjoy!
>
> **Warnings: Graphic depictions of violence**

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 42 — Riprendendo

.

.

.

When Katsuki returned to their bedroom, he found Izuku sleeping soundly. He was swaddled in a tangled heap of blankets with his curls poking out like little sprouts.

Careful not to wake him, Katsuki eased back into bed. Beneath the covers, he searched for Izuku's left hand. His fingers brushed around until they found it. Tenderly, he slipped the eternity ring back onto his husband's finger, placing it exactly where it belonged.

He peeled back the blanket just enough to catch a glimpse of it. The silver band caught in the moonlight.

He *really* fucking hoped he was being paranoid. He didn't want this tracker to ever actually become necessary.

But having it there helped quiet the anxious whispers in his head.

As Katsuki held Izuku's hand in both of his, the other man stirred slightly. Izuku mumbled something unintelligible. Then he instinctively curled closer, drawn to Katsuki's warmth.

A small, tired smile tugged at Katsuki's lips.

He tucked them both deeper under the blankets and wrapped his arms securely around Izuku. He allowed the quiet heat between their bodies to soften every last knot of tension in his body.

This time, when he closed his eyes, sleep came easy.

☽ ☽ ☽

A dark haze infected Katsuki's lucid dream.

He was trying to swim and find a way out. But every direction he turned he encountered nothing but stifling darkness. The blackness grew thicker and thicker until it started to taste like astringent. The acidic burn crawled across his tongue, his eyes, and down his throat. He screamed out in the suffocating, onyx fluid—but no sound came.

Unexpectedly, through the poison smog, he heard Izuku's voice.

"Kacchan!" Izuku shouted.

Katsuki turned, trying to find him. He tried to call back—but his voice was stuck.

"Kacchan, you need to wake up!" Izuku screamed into the darkness.

Hearing Izuku's fear zapped him into action with a shot of pure adrenaline. His lungs expanded and he willed his body to move.

His eyes snapped open.

He was wrenched from his nightmare so violently it took him a second to breathe. His first thought was *Izuku*—his second was *danger*. He shot upright, heart slamming against his ribs. His eyes searched frantically for his husband. But then the moment he moved, the world spun. A wave of nausea crashed over him, and then he coughed—hard.

A sharp, acrid taste burned the back of his throat. His nose stung like he'd inhaled caustic liquid that was meant to kill.

Quickly, he covered his face with his arm and he jumped to his feet.

His eyes scanned the room. He could see a layer of smokey haze filling the space.

His heart stopped. The poison fog in his dream was not fake.

He looked at Izuku in pure, sheer horror when he realized what this meant. They both glanced to the door and saw a grey cloud of gas creep from beneath it. The thick fog rolled in like two hands scraping their way towards them, taking its time to come claim their lives.

Within the next split second, the door to their bedroom slammed open. Both Izuku and Katsuki jerked back, getting ready to strike—but it was Aizawa, covering his mouth with a rag.

Behind him was mayhem. Denki was doubled over, hacking. Sero gagged against the wall, eyes streaming. Monoma had his shirt over his face, scanning the corridor like a cornered animal. Shinsou was coughing while he gripped a long blade in his hands. Miruko stood silent but furious, loading her pistol with practiced speed and trembling restraint.

Aizawa pointed sharply at them, his voice low and urgent through the cloth.

“Below ground,” he hissed. “*Now*.”

Without wasting another second, Aizawa rushed forward. He kicked aside the rug in their room, gripped the hidden handle in the floor, and heaved.

“Everyone get in,” Aizawa ordered.

Then that’s when they heard the foreboding sound of glass breaking. It came from upstairs.

Miruko cursed under her breath and slammed the bedroom door shut. She locked it, bolted it. But it wouldn’t hold for long. The air was turning thick. Katsuki could feel it in his throat, clinging to his lungs like oil.

One by one, they dropped through the hatch.

When they were all safely inside, Aizawa expertly maneuvered the rug back over the top of the secret entrance. That way when he closed it, it would be masked once more. He locked the final bolt and a grim silence spread.

They gasped in the clean air, greedy and loud.

Sero dropped to his knees, coughing uncontrollably. Denki was shaking, his fingers twitched like he couldn’t stop them. Monoma wiped his eyes furiously, blinking through the blur. Shinsou groaned, trying to spit out the taste of the poison that accumulated on his tongue. Izuku clutched Katsuki’s hand in a white-knuckled grip as they both hacked uncontrollably.

Right as Denki was about to say something, Aizawa slapped a hand over his mouth. He put his finger up in a ‘*quiet*’ motion.

They all listened intensely.

Multiple people barged into the cabin. Up above them, they could hear glass breaking and footsteps spread out corner to corner. The movements of the people were ultra organized. Tactical in a way that Katsuki never heard before. His stomach dropped when countless footsteps got closer. He tried to number them and it was damn near impossible.

Aizawa removed his hand from Denki's mouth and motioned to all of them.

"Everyone needs to make a run for the boats at the base of the mountain," Aizawa whispered low and serious. "There's no point in trying to go toe to toe, there's too many. If you get separated, rendezvous in Nemuro. Now, everyone—*go*. Put your gear on and grab what you can as quietly and quickly as possible."

They all scattered.

Everyone began throwing on clothes. Coats, gloves, and boots. They armed themselves with their weapons, and Katsuki wearily glanced at Izuku who was next to him. His husband was gearing up without an ounce of hesitation.

He glanced down at the ring on Izuku's finger.

As the sound of more people flooded into the cabin, everyone picked up the pace. They had stored extra clothes and bags down in the bunker, in case they needed an emergency exit. Katsuki grabbed his backpack pre-packed with guns, knives, and his burner phone. He took out several guns and stored them in cargo pants pockets for easy access.

The others dressed in silence, getting their weapons ready. All of their expressions dived into a lethal seriousness Katsuki had seen a thousand times over.

They began moving hastily toward the emergency exit, each step measured and silent.

But then—the bedroom door above them slammed open. The force used made the floor tremble. A loud creak was followed by a crash. Something heavy hit the ground.

Then came the boots. Dozens of them began stomping and scattering.

Everyone below the floorboards froze. Their breaths lodged in their throats, paralyzed by the threat just inches above their heads. They eyed the thick metal exit door with tight, anxious gazes. Every one of them was poised to move but were terrified of making a single wrong sound.

Aizawa crept forward first. Each of his movements was deliberate and ghostlike. He tried not to betray their position.

And above them, chaos was happening.

The invaders moved with purpose. They wasted no time turning the bedroom inside out. Katsuki could hear the rustling. The bathroom door was thrown open, the closet was searched, and the bed frame was heaved and overturned.

"We can't find them," a man's voice muttered above, annoyed and sharp.

“They couldn’t have gotten too far after we sent that gas bomb down the chimney,” a woman answered.

Katsuki wearily darted a glance to the door—then to Izuku. His husband stood frozen, like he was hearing some sort of sound no one else could. Without a word, Katsuki gently tugged him along. Izuku followed, breath caught somewhere in his lungs.

One by one, they crept toward the emergency door.

Every footstep was a gamble. Sweat dripped down Katsuki’s temple. His jaw clenched so tight he bit through his lip. He tasted blood, but didn’t stop as he moved very carefully.

Then, Katsuki heard *his* voice.

Dread spilled down his spine.

“The trick is listening closely,” Tomura said, voice smooth and too fucking patient. “Because if you do. You can hear the scratching of *vermin* under the floorboards.”

And in an instant, all of Katsuki’s worst fears detonated into reality.

Bullets tore through the ceiling above them like thunder cracking through wood. The trapdoor exploded open as gunfire screamed from above. They ran. Behind them, lead splintered the ceiling of their bunker into a rain of shrapnel. Smoke and poison gas followed, chasing them like the grim reaper. There was no time to think. No time to breathe.

Only to run.

They burst into the brittle cold. The shock of winter air slammed against their skin like a slap to the face. The mountain echoed with howling wind, and all of their boots frantically crunched the fresh snow as they ran for their lives.

All of Katsuki’s thoughts began to blur. His paranoia and anxiety spiked, making him spiral.

As he sprinted, Katsuki forced himself to focus. He gritted his teeth as he shoved aside all the shouting voices. He activated his tunnel vision and focused on only one goal: get Izuku to safety.

Snow crashed down around them in violent sheets, blanketing the mountainside in blinding white. It was a near whiteout—until the white was ruptured with flashes of red.

Explosions of blood and muzzle flares painted the storm in violence.

The Yakuza were swarming. Hundreds of them poured down the mountain like a black tide. Their faces were twisted and marked with the ink of the Shie Hassaikai. Their war cries split the storm as they threw themselves at them with reckless brutality.

Their team fought back with everything they had. Steel slashed. Bullets cut. Fists flew.

But they were drowning in numbers.

Their enemy moved like a living creature. A writhing, endless thing with too many limbs and too many teeth. For every man struck down, two more surged forward.

Soon, their team was forced to split up.

“Go! We’ll hold them back!” Miruko shouted as she ducked behind another tree. She shot from around the trunk. “We need to split up and shake them off!”

Miruko and Aizawa were the first to break off, carving a bloody path through the snow. Then Monoma, Denki, and Sero were dragged sideways into a skirmish too thick to escape. The mountain swallowed them in layers, one by one, they peeled away by necessity to get to safety.

Shinsou, him and Izuku ran as fast as they could to the cable car.

“We’re going towards the ski lift!” Shinsou shouted. “At this rate we’re not going to make it down by foot. The cable car will get us down quicker!”

He and Shinsou flanked Izuku on either side. All three of them sprinted through the storm, boots slipping, and breaths ragged. The cable car was their only hope. It was the one way down the mountain before the whole peak turned into a gravesite.

But just as it came into view, glowing faintly through the snowfall like salvation—

—they were surrounded.

From the trees, like a nightmare given form, a man emerged.

The Yakuza brute was enormous. He was packed with muscle and menace, his single good eye gleamed with violent intent. Cold air fumed from his mouth as he barreled forward, heavy and fast.

Shinsou didn’t hesitate. He pivoted on his heel with that same lethal speed Katsuki had seen in him time and time again. His first strike was too fast to track until it landed. The thug reeled as Shinsou ducked a wild grab. He drove an elbow hard into the man’s ribs. Then he spun and drove his heel into the side of the man’s knee.

A sharp crack echoed. The man screamed.

But Shinsou wasn’t done. He grabbed him by the collar, twisted, and slammed his skull against the steel girder of the station.

Once. Twice. He did it until the body dropped, fully limp. The man slid down, leaving a thick smear of blood behind him.

They moved again. Faster this time.

Katsuki was swearing in his head, eyes burning. All he could see was Izuku chained somewhere in the dark. Hurt and alone. The thought lit desperation inside him. His pulse surged. He forcefully pushed Izuku to the front.

Then he quickly hoisted Izuku by the waist and shoved him frantically into the cable car.

Footsteps pounded behind them.

Katsuki spun around just in time to see another swarm break through the trees. Dozens of Yakuza poured. They were armed with guns, knives, and brass knuckles—and they attacked them without hesitation.

Katsuki met the first with a blow that cracked like thunder. His fists moved fast, each strike brutal and practiced. One dropped. Another took his place. He twisted. Pulled his gun. He fired—and two more went down in bursts of scarlet.

Beside him, Shinsou danced through the shadows. His blade carved clean arcs through the air, cutting down anyone that stepped in range. Every dodge was sharp. Every swing was decisive. They moved as one. Side-by-side, honed by missions from the past. Katsuki took high. Shinsou swept low. They covered each other in a silent rhythm as bodies piled up around them.

But they weren't winning—they were merely scraping by.

And then, another wave of attackers came.

Katsuki suddenly heard movement behind him. His head snapped around—Izuku was trying to climb back out of the cable car. He began to shout, but Shinsou beat him to it.

"Stay there!" Shinsou barked, voice sharp as a whip crack.

Katsuki's eyes met Shinsou's. The space between them charged with an unspoken communication.

Then Shinsou turned, with blood streaking his cheek, and shouted, "I'll see you two at the rendezvous point!"

Katsuki bolted for the car. Someone tried to grab his leg, but Shinsou cut the man's hand off with a sharp swing of his blade. Blood sprayed across his face as Katsuki hoisted himself up and in the car.

Then Shinsou made a sprint for the control panel.

A blade cut across his arm, but he didn't waver. Another Yakuza lunged, but Shinsou dodged, rolled, and came up swinging. His fist collided with the attacker's temple so hard that blood sprayed.

He reached the switch.

He punched it to full speed.

The cable car jolted.

The cart surged forward with a mechanical whir that echoed across the mountainside. The jolt of motion snapped Katsuki forward, and Izuku too. Both of them clutched at each other instinctively, bracing as the car rocketed away from the station.

Cold air slammed into Katsuki's face like a punch from nature itself. His heart thundered straight into his throat as the station behind them began to shrink into the distance.

Below, Shinsou was still fighting for his life.

They saw him twist an enemy's arm until the joint gave with a sickening pop. Then he pivoted with terrifying precision as he used the limp body as a shield against the next attacker's blade. The machete lodged between the man's ribs, and Shinsou responded with a brutal kick that landed squarely in the next man's chest.

Red bloomed across the snow like spilled ink.

As they got further, the bodies blurred together. Movement and color meshed into shadow as distance swallowed the shapes of the figures below. The car continued to descend, groaning along its cable. It carried them deeper down the mountainside until fog turned the entire world above them into a smear of white and gray nothingness.

Beside him, Izuku clung to the cold steel bar with trembling hands.

His eyes were dark with fear and brimmed with tears. His breath came fast and shallow, showing how horrified he was by the splintering of their team.

"They'll be okay," Katsuki tried to reassure, his voice taut and low. He spat a thick glob of blood to the floor, and wiped his mouth with the back of his glove. "Don't worry. We've been in tighter situations as a unit before."

Izuku turned to him, uncertain.

He didn't respond, but the way he stared made it clear—he wasn't sure if he believed that. Katsuki could see it. But he did believe it. He *had* to. They'd survived worse and sure as hell would survive this.

Then, a shriek split the sky above them.

It was the sharp sound of metal on metal. It was high and sharp—but it sounded dead wrong.

Their heads snapped up simultaneously. Instinct overrode everything else.

Suddenly, the cable line snagged.

It jerked violently and the entire car lurched forward. The force snapped them both backwards. And Katsuki's shoulder hit the side hard. Izuku's skull slammed into the window behind him. Startled, a yelp tore out of Izuku's throat. But before Katsuki could curse or reach for him—another snap.

This one was louder and sharper.

Then, the line gave out.

And the world fell.

The car sheared off the cable like a blade torn from its scabbard, clean and deadly. Gravity yanked them downward in a single merciless motion and the mountain opened up below like a black hole. They plummeted, fast. The velocity was too ferocious for thought and all too quick for them to brace.

Katsuki's stomach dropped like a stone. His vision tunneled.

They both screamed.

Izuku's arms wrapped around his torso and his face buried in his neck. Katsuki threw his arms over Izuku's head, locked them there, and he twisted them in midair. He steeled himself to eat the brunt of the incoming impact.

And when it came, the pain was blinding.

The cable car hit the ground and they were slammed into the metal floor.

Glass exploded outward in a furious storm of jagged shrapnel, slicing the air. The car bounced, skidded, and twisted midair. Then it slammed again, harder this time. They clung to each other as they were helplessly tossed around. Steel groaned and screeched beneath them, twisting like paper. Each bounce threw them into the walls. Each crash bent the car further out of shape.

It was a wild, savage descent.

Wind screamed through shattered windows. Cold kicked them in the face. The floor tore open. The ceiling buckled. Snow surged inside like smoke, swirling violently as they rolled. It was like the entire cable car turned into a metal coffin skidding down the mountain.

Then—another impact.

A final collision occurred, heavy and immediate.

The cart smashed into something massive and unmovable. The force hit so hard Katsuki felt Izuku's body seize up against him. Somewhere in that moment, Izuku gagged, mouth full of stomach acid, the force jostling it up his throat.

The car tipped.

It lifted again, a sickening weightless moment. And then it dropped back to earth with a shattering, thunderous crash that made the ground shudder beneath it.

Everything went still.

Neither of them moved.

A silence so deadly followed that for a moment, Katsuki worried he had passed away right then. Then he heard the distant hiss of snow melting against hot metal. Pain bloomed in full clarity now. His ribs ached. Glass was lodged deep in his back. Blood trickled hot down his face, soaking his lips.

He pushed through the shock, driven by the need to keep Izuku safe.

He moved first.

Katsuki hissed in enormous pain as he tried to peel himself upright. Blood dripped from a deep gash under his eye. He nursed his temple and tried to stop the world from spinning.

Izuku did the same. Broken glass fragments cut into his gloves as he tried to find leverage to pull himself up. Katsuki shoved a jagged sheet of metal out of the way that had fallen from the ceiling. He staggered upright with a groan that sounded less like a man in pain and more like an animal trying to escape from a trap.

He stood to his full height, and tried to find an exit.

All around him, was ruin. The once smooth metal was bent and torn in several places. The windows were entirely gone, and in their place were sharp left over shards of glass like teeth.

His hands searched everywhere.

He knew they didn't have much time. A crash like that was loud and bound to draw attention. Katsuki yelled out a loud grunt as he pushed against the jammed door on the side. His neck flexed with effort as he gave a full strength haul.

The door shrieked and surrendered to Katsuki, popping open and falling to the ground.

Suddenly, the sound of Izuku coughing split the air.

Katsuki spun towards him. Izuku was doubled over, blood slicking down his chin. Each breath he took sounded like a damn rattle in his chest. Katsuki's heart dropped—then plummeted further when he saw the shards of glass embedded in Izuku's legs, glinting red and white like broken bones.

Izuku tried to speak—but choked. Another gout of blood wetted his lips.

Katsuki dropped to his knees. He swept Izuku into his arms, keeping his grip firm, but gentle.

"C'mon," Katsuki rasped. With effort, he hoisted Izuku and carried him as best as he could. "We have to keep moving."

Izuku hissed in agony, the glass in his legs shifting with every movement.

"I got you," Katsuki whispered shakily as he exited the tattered cable car. "I got you, don't worry, darling."

His voice cracked on the last word.

He ran.

The cold singed across his face. Each step burned and his cut up back screamed in protest. But he kept moving, faster and faster—because there was no other option.

Behind them stretched silence. There was no shouting. No gunfire. Not even footsteps. The only thing that lingered was an awful, unnatural quiet. It pressed in around them like a tomb and made him move quicker and quicker.

His breath tore from him in sharp bursts. He pulled Izuku tighter and closer. His husband's arms were weak around his neck, trembling faintly. Izuku's breath hitched and cracked against his collarbone. Every inhale punctuated by another coughing fit.

Katsuki kept his eyes forward, tunnel vision sharp. Every step was aimed toward the rendezvous point—where he knew with full confidence his team would be waiting.

So he didn't look back.

He ran into the dark, with Izuku bleeding in his arms. The weight of everything he loved hung in the balance as he bolted as quickly as he could.

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki ran the entire way to the coastline without stopping.

His lungs were in flames. His legs were burning. But never once did he break his pace. Trees blurred past in streaks of shadow, and the only sounds that kept them company were the harsh crunch of snow underfoot and Katsuki's ragged, relentless breathing.

At some point, Izuku had dug the shards of glass from his thighs. The cuts were deep, angry, and bleeding.

But Katsuki knew his husband was tough enough to grit through it.

They rounded a bend and one of the marked docks came into view. Its silhouette rose out of the fog like a lifeline. Katsuki sighed out of sheer relief. The small boat Aizawa said was hidden was there, its form tucked under a heavy tarp that flapped violently in the ocean wind.

They both scanned the area for danger, shoulders taut.

But the clearing was quiet and barren.

"Do you think the others made it?" Izuku asked, voice tight with worry.

"They'll be fine," Katsuki replied. His tone was firm despite the tremor of exertion in his breath. "We've done this before. Whenever there's too many people to take out, everyone is really good at getting to safety. We'll see them soon, don't worry."

They moved onto the dock. With deliberate care, Katsuki lowered Izuku to his feet, watching closely as he stretched out his legs, testing what adrenaline hadn't already numbed.

Izuku winced but gave a nod. He could move and that was enough.

Katsuki stepped to the tarp and yanked it away in one sharp motion. The canvas caught the wind and fluttered off into the dark. Beneath it sat a small white-and-blue motor skiff. It was bare-bones, unassuming, but seaworthy.

“C’mon, darling,” Katsuki urged.

Izuku nodded and followed. He let Katsuki help guide him into the rocking boat. The water slapped against the hull as Izuku stepped in. He caught Katsuki’s hands and steadied himself. Their fingers locked. Katsuki turned and Izuku helped him get in just the same.

Then suddenly, as Katsuki was halfway inside, a strange sound cut through the wind.

It was sharp, clean, and almost delicate.

Piercing pain sunk into his neck.

Katsuki choked and stumbled.

Their eyes locked, both wide with horrified recognition. Like watching a slow-motion nightmare come to life, they saw too late the tiny dart embedded into the side of Katsuki’s throat.

Izuku scrambled out of the boat and Katsuki staggered backwards.

With a snarl, Katsuki ripped the dart free and flung it aside. But it had already given its kiss of death.

The tranquilizer was working fast. The world began to tilt and stumble out of focus. His nerves ignited, trembling with foreign heat. Then next his muscles turned to cement. His vision glossed over and his stomach churned as though he’d taken a hundred gut punches. And then finally, his limbs stopped listening to him.

He tried to fight it. But he couldn’t. His knees buckled and he dropped.

The last thing he heard was the anguished sound of Izuku’s voice screaming, “Kacchan!”

And then—black.

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki gasped awake.

His eyes snapped open and he found his world was on its side. Then came pain. It surged up his legs, arms, and beat against the back of his skull. He moaned and suddenly a bile flavored cough wrecked his chest. Katsuki spat out a sloppy wad of blood, gritting through the sharp, metallic taste of iron.

His memory came in pieces. Every bit was blurry, and incoherent.

The boat. The paralyzer bullet soaring through the air. Izuku's scream—

He stiffened.

Izuku. Where was *Izuku*?

His head whipped around, too fast. The edges of his vision pulsed with static. Shapes blurred. Then cleared. Across from him, slumped against the metal floor, was Izuku. His body was limp and he was gagged by a cloth. Moreover, his wrists and ankles were bound with coarse rope.

And he was unconscious.

Katsuki tried to lunge forward—only to barely move.

He looked down. Thick industrial-grade zip ties bound his hands in front of him. His restraints were so tight they were digging into his flesh, turning it raw. His skin throbbed with every heartbeat and the edges of the plastic bit deep into him. But worse than the pain was the stiffness still clinging to his limbs. The paralytic hadn't worn off completely.

He tried to move his legs. They barely twitched.

The world clarified steadily. He was on his side, tossed carelessly into the back of a van. The interior was stripped to bare metal. No windows. Just him and Izuku flung inside like discarded trash and all their bags and belongings were gone.

Katsuki strained his neck, fighting the dead weight in his body. He clawed himself inch by inch across the freezing floor towards Izuku. The van jolted suddenly. His shoulder slammed into the wall. He groaned, nausea swelling like a tide.

He gritted his teeth and forced himself forward.

Each scrape along the floor rattled the bones in his arms. But finally, *finally*, he reached his husband. He leaned over as much as his stiff body would allow and pressed into Izuku's side.

"Izuku," he rasped, voice shredded with urgency. He tried again, harsher. "Izuku. Wake up."

Nothing.

Izuku was out cold.

His breathing was shallow, almost barely noticeable. It was then Katsuki saw that his lips had a faint bluish tinge. His lashes didn't flutter as much as they did usually in his sleep—and it was concerning. It was like someone had drugged him to the edge of death and held him there, suspended in stasis.

Katsuki's gut twisted. The helpless rage that surged up threatened to choke him.

Think, he hissed at himself. *Move, goddamnit*.

He shifted, fumbling awkwardly until he could bring his wrists up to his mouth. The plastic dug deeper. He ignored it. He paused and looked at his hands. He went for the part of the zip ties that could be hidden when pressed against his body.

He bared his teeth and bit down hard on the thick band of plastic. It was tougher than any zip tie he'd ever encountered. But Katsuki pushed.

Fueled by panic and fury, Katsuki ground his incisors against the tie.

☽ ☽ ☽

Wherever they were taking them, it was far.

Katsuki mentally tracked the time. Over an hour and a half had passed.

He couldn't guess where they were or what the fuck was happening. He wondered how long he had been passed out before he came to. He hoped it wasn't long, but he had a feeling they were very far away from the rendezvous point.

Sweat pooled at the base of Katsuki's neck as he chewed relentlessly at the zip ties.

He hadn't stopped a single minute of the way. His teeth were beginning to go numb, and faint shocks of pain bloomed in his gums. But he didn't even consider taking a break.

The plastic was giving, little by little, and that was exactly what he needed.

As the minutes dragged on, his strength gradually returned. He flexed against the restraints in small bursts, bleeding slightly each time the edge of the tie cut into him. It was slow progress, but it was what was going to save both him and Izuku.

By the time the van began to slow, the restraints were halfway chewed through.

Katsuki's stomach turned when he heard the gear shift click into park. Next, the crunch of boots in the snow approached and he estimated it was well over a dozen people coming.

Panic prickled at his spine. He bared his teeth and gave one final, vicious bite with his canine. He twisted his wrists, testing the damage—and the plastic nearly gave way.

Katsuki sucked in a sharp breath, eyes wide.

He could break free.

But timing would be everything now.

He quickly pressed the worn down part of the zip ties flush against his body, hiding it from view.

The van's back doors flew open with a metallic bang.

The first thing Katsuki registered were the twelve Yakuza grunts. They were dressed head to toe in black and they clutched a mix of guns and swords. Each one was twitching with anticipation.

The second detail he clocked were the Vipers. In stark contrast, they were cloaked in white from neck to boot. Their faces were hidden behind unsettling porcelain masks with only eye slits carved into the surface. And in their gloved hands were sleek, matte-black rifles held with quiet precision.

But the third thing he noticed was the sky. It was still dark.

Which meant dawn hadn't come yet, and less than three hours had passed.

They were still on Hokkaido. That meant they could still make it to the rendezvous point.

Suddenly, the van rocked as the men swarmed in. Hands grabbed at him and Izuku. They were rough and merciless. Katsuki grunted as several Yakuza yanked him upright and shoved him out of the van.

His eyes darted frantically. He searched through the flurry of movement until he landed on Izuku.

Katsuki's chest seized.

Izuku was still unconscious, limp in the arms of a different man. The bastard was holding him gently. It felt like a twisted mockery of care, cradling him like a precious gem to be sold.

"This way," one of the men barked. "Move it."

Katsuki stumbled forward as they forced him to walk into the wintry dark. His breath puffed harshly in front of him, thick and ragged.

Around them, there was nothing. There were no streetlights. No buildings. Just an empty, snow-covered road in the middle of nowhere. The thick blanket of white blurred the landscape into anonymity. Katsuki strained to recognize anything.

He tried to find a detail that might give him an edge—but everything looked the same.

Then, just as he thought he saw a familiar slope in the distance, a figure emerged.

Katsuki's breath caught. Rage surged through him so fast it left his hands trembling.

There, standing like a ghost summoned from hell, was the man he wanted to kill more than any one.

Tomura's face was expressionless, and his eyes were colder than the winter winds. He was dressed annoyingly perfectly in a pure white coat, hat, gloves and pants. His white boots stood on top of the snow and he was poised like a deadly blizzard himself.

"Bakugou Katsuki," Tomura greeted slowly.

His voice was smooth and deceptively soft. Much like when frost formed over skin right before it burned.

“This wasn’t how I hoped we’d see each other again,” Tomura said with an edge of mock disappointment. “But either way, thank you for giving my brother back to me.”

A muscle in Katsuki’s cheek twitched. He bared his teeth in a snarl.

He looked past Tomura to Izuku. There, his lover hung limp in another man’s arms. Izuku’s head was tilted back, curls spilling downward exposing his blood-smeared face. His chest still moved, slow and shallow.

“No words?” Tomura tilted his head. “Really? Not even from a loudmouth like you?”

Katsuki cut his eyes at Tomura and glared.

“I have nothing to say to you,” he growled.

“Pity.” Tomura walked closer. He stopped just short of Katsuki and studied him. “I have to give you your flowers,” Tomura complimented. “You gave me a fair run around. More than anyone else has before.”

And I’m not done, Katsuki thought sourly. He carefully kept his wrists close to his stomach, hiding the weakened point in the zip ties.

Tomura pivoted sharply and pointed forward without a word.

The entire crowd began to move in perfect, chilling sync. Katsuki gritted his teeth as he was yanked along, legs half-asleep and full of lead. Each step sent sharp, biting pain up his calves, needling through his core as they marched him deeper into the winter-dark.

When they made their way through a small passage, suddenly everything began feeling familiar.

Too familiar.

Then Katsuki’s eyes widened when he saw the Bakugou estate gates.

“What the fuck is going on?” he snapped. His voice rose with panic as he began to fight the grip of the men on either side of him. “Why are we *here*?!”

Tomura didn’t stop walking.

“No place like home, right?” he replied easily. He casted a cold glance over his shoulder. “I thought this would be a fitting place for you to meet your end. I did some digging and it turns out—you were born here. Did you know that? Home birth with a midwife, very charming. Your mother filed the paperwork at the hospital later.”

Katsuki’s gut twisted as the group trudged through the garden and towards the back.

Along the way, he saw flashes of his mother's ghost walking past. He felt the eyes of family members he never met watch their sacred place be defiled.

When they made a sharp left turn, his gut dropped.

They were at his family's gravesite.

Tomura marched right up to the grave marked 'Bakugou Mitsuki' and stopped. But right next to it Katsuki found a goddamn headstone with his name on it. It was black, perfectly new, and in front of it was a shallow grave dug deep enough for a body.

But what shook him to his core was the black wooden coffin, laying off to the side.

Katsuki's breath came fast and shallow, fogging in the cold.

They were going to try to kill him—*here*.

"Poetic a bit, isn't it?" Tomura taunted. "Your birth and death location will be the same."

"You're fucking *deranged*!" Katsuki yelled, trying to wrench forward. One of the men holding him slammed a fist into his stomach. Katsuki coughed and doubled, snow biting into his knees.

Tomura crouched to Katsuki's level, narrowing his eyes. "I think that's rich coming from someone like *you*."

Katsuki ground his teeth down. He groaned from the brutal blow, and tried his best to not show weakness. But he couldn't help it. His vulnerability began to rear its head, because all he could think about was how he might've failed Izuku.

Katsuki's eyes flicked towards his husband.

Naturally, Tomura's eyes followed. But they lingered a second too long on Izuku.

At this, Katsuki paused.

He stared at Tomura and realized he had one chance to dig his heels in. If they were going to make it out alive, he needed to apply pressure to all the weak points Tomura had. He swallowed and readjusted his approach.

"Do you really think selling him to Chisaki makes you some kind of protector?" Katsuki whispered cruelly. "If you do this, you'll be hurting him. But I'm sure you're used to that. All you've *ever* done is hurt him all his life."

Tomura's face didn't twitch. "I'm the only reason he's lived this long."

"And you're going to be the reason he's dead inside."

For a moment, neither of them spoke.

The wind howled louder, as if the winter itself was bracing for violence.

Katsuki couldn't tell if the words had hit their mark. If they did, Tomura didn't show it. Instead, the intimidating man slowly rose to his full height with his coat billowing behind him. Without so much as a glance back, he addressed one of the Vipers standing at attention nearby.

"When Izuku wakes up, we can get started," Tomura commanded. "I want to make sure Izuku witnesses his death."

The two men gripping Katsuki moved. Katsuki struggled and twisted, and it earned him a blow to the ribs. He began thrashing as much as he could as they dragged him towards the headstone. He watched with terror as six of the Yakuza and Vipers began to get shovels and prepared the coffin by removing the lid.

"If you go through with this Izuku will *never* forgive you!" Katsuki shouted. "He'll hate you until his very last breath!"

Tomura didn't turn.

"He'll understand, eventually," he said softly. "He always does."

"No," Katsuki warned. "He won't this time."

And for a second, something flickered behind Tomura's eyes—just briefly.

It was dark, but it was uncertain.

The Yakuza men holding him forced Katsuki to kneel into the snow. The cold bit into his skin through his clothes and his head hung low. He clenched his jaw and rigidness seized his shoulders in both defiance and terror.

Suddenly three men with rifles circled him like vultures. They pointed their guns dead at him. He watched helplessly as the man holding Izuku placed him down in the snow, directly across from the grave for the perfect view of the execution.

Katsuki screwed his eyes shut.

He hoped Izuku never woke up.

Not for his sake, but for Izuku's. If he had to die, he hoped he did out of sight.

Suddenly, real fear filled Katsuki. It pressed down on him with the weight of inevitability, sharp and cold as a machete against his throat. He held his breath without meaning to, fully paralyzed. For a fleeting second, he wondered if this was the kind of terror the people he'd killed felt before their end. It was a hollow, dizzying realization that all his luck had finally run out.

A muffled cry cut into the dead silence.

Katsuki's head snapped up, and he and Izuku's eyes met.

His lover's expression was dazed, terrified, and achingly lost.

Panic and confusion warred across his face. He thrashed instinctively, only to be seized by two massive Yakuza enforcers. They wrenched him upright onto his knees, arms pinned, and Izuku gasped through his nose, trying to scream through the gag shoved in his mouth.

"Ah. Finally awake," Tomura spoke.

Tomura began walking towards Izuku, and a vile sensation uncoiled in Katsuki.

He had always known of Izuku's Big Brother that lurked in the shadows. He was this ominous dark legend in the background of stories. Proof of his existence echoed in bruises on Izuku's skin and the smallness in his voice. Up until now, Katsuki never saw them actually interact. He could only imagine it.

But now, the ugliness of it all stood clear in front of him.

His eyes darted between the two brothers. In the narrow space separating them, Katsuki could see the poisoned power imbalance. He saw the tight look of control etched into Tomura's face. And on Izuku's—

On Izuku's face was a kind of fear Katsuki had never seen before.

It was old, and clearly familiar.

Katsuki felt his heartbreak for his lover.

"I'm only half sorry for the headache you must have," Tomura said coldly to Izuku. "We had to hit you with extra dosages for obvious reasons."

Izuku screamed again, fully guttural. He was trying to say something, but it was pointless. The gag was keeping anything he could say confined inside of him. Tomura turned his back on Izuku, the action very clearly punishing and Izuku began to cry.

Tomura then walked straight up to Katsuki. He glared down at him like he was trash to be disposed of.

Izuku thrashed harder. He tried to say something but once again, no words came out.

"However," Tomura continued. "I am fully sorry that it took me so long to come collect you. I admittedly have known where you were the last three weeks. But Chisaki had this headstone specially made and it was only delivered today."

Tomura delicately ran a gloved finger down the curve of the headstone.

"He has a twisted sense of humor," Tomura taunted. "At least now you'll be next to your dearest mother, Katsuki. Mother and son. Forever side by side, doomed by the weight of their mistakes."

“Fuck you,” Katsuki sneered through gritted teeth. “I’m going to kill you with my bare hands after this.”

Their gazes collided. Searing heat met glacial indifference and the silence between them quivered like a taut wire on the brink of snapping.

Tomura’s upper lip curled, and his expression grew icier by the second. He slowly walked back over to Izuku and crouched down to his level. He hooked his finger under the gag and with a sharp flick of his wrist, he slipped the rag down from Izuku’s mouth.

“Tomura,” Izuku sobbed, fully unraveling in the smallest voice Katsuki ever heard him use. “I’m sorry—” another wrecked sob. “I’m sorry. Don’t hurt him. Please.”

Tomura’s eyes glared down at him.

He didn’t say a word, and the whole time Izuku never stopped begging. He groveled with all he had and Katsuki felt his heart break more and more as he watched. With every plea Izuku gave, he could see Tomura soak it up and wield it like a weapon as a confirmation of his influence over Izuku.

“Don’t hurt him,” Izuku begged. “Tomura, I love him. Please.”

Tomura didn’t waiver.

“You know he doesn’t care about you, Izuku,” Tomura berated. “Did he tell you about our deal?”

Suddenly, everything went still.

Katsuki’s heart didn’t just skip—it flatlined.

The world around him collapsed into a dead stillness, a vacuum where sound and breath ceased to exist. Dread crashed down his spine like a falling blade. And the sharp edge of it carved through every one of his nerves.

His lips began to move, quiet and frantic. “No, no, no, no—”

He saw it hit Izuku.

He watched the confusion seize Izuku mid-struggle. His thrashing completely stopped. His wide eyes flicked between Katsuki and Tomura, searching desperately for someone to tell him this wasn’t what it sounded like.

And Tomura, a true master of weaponization, ceased the moment.

“Ah.” Tomura clasped his hands. “He didn’t tell you.”

Izuku’s silence deepened. He looked again at Katsuki. In that uncertain blink, Katsuki saw the doubt starting to settle.

“Izuku,” Katsuki rasped, voice serrated with desperation.

He lunged forward, fighting against the bite of the zip ties. He cried out only to be slammed back by a Yakuza thug. The muzzle of a rifle jammed between his eyes. But Katsuki didn’t care. The terror of losing Izuku’s trust burned more than any bullet ever could.

“Izuku, I swear to god I was going to tell you—”

“—He was going to trade you in,” Tomura cut in. “Hand-deliver you to me like an offering. Just for a shot at his pathetic revenge.”

“I changed my mind!” Katsuki screamed, his voice cracking wide open. His face contorted with grief and fury as he glared at Tomura, spitting the words like fire. “You know I changed my mind the second I realized who the fuck you were!”

Tomura didn’t blink. “Still,” he said. “The thought alone is proof enough you don’t deserve Izuku.”

Katsuki lost it.

His whole body convulsed with rage. He fought with everything he had left in him—screaming, sobbing, straining—until another guard had to step in just to keep him upright.

“No! No, Izuku, please—I had changed my fucking mind!” Katsuki’s voice shredded, consumed with remorse. “Izuku, I—”

But the rest didn’t come.

The words were caught in his throat, razor-sharp and unforgiving. His chest heaved as the words turned to ash behind his teeth. Blood, dirt, and tears mingled down his face as his mouth worked uselessly, trying to say what couldn’t be unsaid.

“I’m so fucking sorry,” Katsuki apologized through his sobs. “I—I didn’t know everything back then. I didn’t have the whole picture or know anything. I was so fucking *angry*, Izuku. I was blinded by my rage—”

Tomura rolled his eyes and snapped his fingers. “Gag him.”

A guard moved before Katsuki could get another breath out.

A filthy rag was jammed into his mouth, silencing him mid-sentence. Katsuki convulsed in protest. His wrists shredded against the zip ties. He kept trying, even through the pain—even through the silence. His mouth couldn’t speak anymore, so his eyes screamed for him instead.

Please. Please forgive me. I’m sorry, I love you.

Izuku stared back, unmoving. His eyes were wide, tear-filled, and trembling on the edge of shattering.

Katsuki clung to Izuku's gaze. He was desperate to pour everything he couldn't say into a single look.

The weight of his own failure crushed him. How could he have been so fucking *stupid?* Every silent moment, every held breath, and every swallowed confession echoed back at him like a countdown to ruin. All because he hadn't wanted to tip Izuku over the edge.

And here was Tomura, not only tipping—he was shoving Izuku over the edge, hoping to break him.

"I told you Izuku," Tomura calmly said. "I may be cruel, but I would never lie to you. Unlike me, this mutt jumped at the idea to trade you in to me, all for a shot to kill Chisaki. I told him if he brought me you, he could get his revenge—and he *agreed*."

Katsuki shook his head violently, mouth straining behind the gag.

But Tomura kept going.

"How else do you think he found you so quickly after the masquerade?" Tomura's voice twisted the truth into a dagger. "*I'm* the one who told him what car you took after noticing which one was missing from the garage."

Izuku was shaking his head in denial.

But in his eyes, Katsuki saw exactly what he didn't want to happen, happen.

Izuku broke.

His face crumbled and his body wilted like it was too small to carry the hurt.

The trust they had built fractured like glass underneath Tomura's boot. It scattered across the snow in glittering silence. And Tomura picked up every shard. He turned each one in his hands like a sculptor admiring his work. He shaped the destruction he crafted into exactly the form he wanted.

Katsuki folded forward. His shoulders trembled with silent, uncontrollable sobs.

He was burning alive in shame. His tears fell freely. They stung as they slid over bruises, mixing with blood and into the new gash under his eye. He tried, still, to translate a thousand apologies through his eyes. Every sorry he'd waited too long to say. Every I love you he should've shouted from the rooftops.

Then Tomura sighed. He stood up and brushed his white pants.

"We're done here," Tomura announced, already turning away. "I've wasted enough time with this childish runaround. Bring in the coffin."

Katsuki's veins turned to ice.

His brain stuttered, struggling to process what was going to happen next. But Izuku instantly went pale. Katsuki saw Izuku's heartbreak become eclipsed by a wave of pure dread.

"Coffin?" Izuku whispered, barely audible.

Katsuki and Izuku's head snapped toward the shadows, and there it was.

Half-obscured in the dark stood a long wooden box. Four Vipers emerged and surrounded it, their movements clean and practiced. In eerie silence, they lifted it together and began to carry it forward. Their boots struck the frozen ground in perfect rhythm, like a funeral march composed just for Katsuki.

The coffin neared.

Katsuki could see it clearly now. It was long, narrow, and built from coarse wood stained the color of nothingness.

A sharp, wounded breath tore from Izuku's lungs.

Katsuki turned just in time to see the explosion of horror break across Izuku's face. His body jerked forward violently as pure panic seized him. A scream broke loose from his chest that sounded nearly primal.

"*No*!" Izuku cried, voice fraying apart. "Stop! Tomura, *please*! Don't do this!"

Tomura didn't flinch. He didn't even turn.

"You're still bleeding through your heart for him?" Tomura asked. The words were as brutal as they were calm. His tone had all the cold patience of someone explaining a hard truth to a child who refused to listen. "Even after what I just told you? You really are foolish, Izuku. But I suppose that's my fault for sheltering you so much."

The coffin touched the ground with a heavy, inevitable thud.

"Tomura, please don't—" Izuku begged. He looked up to Tomura with bleary eyes. "Big Brother, don't do th-this. I'll marry Chisaki—I'll go back with you, I swear. I'll do whatever you want, just—don't kill him. Please. *Please*—"

But Tomura said nothing and Katsuki's heart stung hearing that string of words.

Izuku, even now, was still pleading with all he had—offering himself up for Katsuki's sake.

Tomura circled behind Izuku in silence, like a noose drawing closed. Then, without a word, he grabbed the cloth and forced it between Izuku's lips. He tied the gag mercilessly tight. The force jerked Izuku's head back until his jaw trembled with pain. Katsuki heard Izuku whimper as the cloth cut into his skin. He tried to fight, but the paralyzer still dragged down his limbs like chains.

Katsuki flexed his wrists subtly, testing the weakened zip ties once more.

This was his chance to break free.

He drew in a deep breath. He braced every nerve in his body, readying to strike.

Then, without warning, the two hulking Yakuza guards yanked him upright. His boots scraped against the frozen ground, but his eyes were already scanning for a break. He found it.

Now! He ordered himself.

He bucked hard, launching his shoulder into one man's gut with enough force to stagger him. He drove his head back into the nose of the other, then spun and slammed his elbow into someone's ribs. A crack echoed out. He didn't care who it came from. He moved fast and viciously. Like a whirlwind of raw instinct and precision.

For a breathless second, it seemed like he might pull it off. His mind sprinted through routes, options, and every angle. But right as he saw one scenario that they would both make it out alive—four rifles cocked in perfect unison.

Cold steel kissed Katsuki's back, ribs, and his temple.

He forced himself still.

He clenched his jaw so tight it ached. With a heaving chest, he looked around. Twelve weapons. Twelve killers. All of them were highly trained, uninjured, and unflinching.

Katsuki was cornered, and he couldn't see any way out.

Then his eyes drifted to the coffin. It sat there, black and silent, like a goddamn invitation to Hell. The guards didn't wait. They dragged him toward it and shoved him to stand before it.

The wood loomed taller up close, and his headstone gleamed under the pale moonlight.

Katsuki steadied himself. His eyes began to sting, tears breaking through his threshold. That fear came back again, full force. For the first time in a long time, Katsuki wasn't in control. He genuinely didn't know if he was going to die here or not, and that made him terrified.

But he refused to let a bastard like Tomura see it. So Katsuki put on his best, hardened face and ignored the painful uncertainty that knocked at his door.

Tomura approached Katsuki. Their gazes clashed with control and loathing. Tomura gestured for one of the Yakuza men to de-gag Katsuki. When the cloth fell, Tomura stared expectantly at him.

"Any more lies you want to confess?" Tomura mocked.

Katsuki's lip curled. Then he reared back and spat directly in Tomura's face.

The impact landed like a backhand.

Tomura flinched, eyes snapping shut for half a second. But he didn't lash out. He simply reached up and wiped the mess from his cheek with his gloved fingers. When his hand fell, his face had changed. He was no longer smug or cold, but he was furious.

Good, Katsuki thought spitefully.

Tomura took a single step back, rage burning in his stare like black fire.

"Actually," Tomura muttered, as if suddenly remembering a misplaced trinket. He extended his hand with the same cold indifference one might offer to collect a knife. "I almost forgot —"

One of the Vipers stepped forward and silently withdrew a folder tucked beneath their arm. Without even looking at them, Tomura took it with fluid ease. He peeled open the flap and plucked out a stapled set of documents.

Then he turned to face Izuku.

Katsuki's confusion bristled immediately. What the hell was that?

Tomura threw the papers to the ground in front of Izuku.

"You haven't been married for an entire goddamn *month*," Tomura hissed.

Katsuki's eyes locked onto the page closest to the ground, the one that landed askew and caught the moonlight just right.

He read the header and a vital part of him ruptured.

The Official Divorce of Bakugou Katsuki and Mamushi Izuku.

Finalized.

The printed words were a stab through the heart.

Pain flared like a fresh wound cracking open from the inside out. His chest caved in and his breath shuttered. The shock stuck deeper than any wound ever could. He felt the invisible red string that bound him to Izuku break. It was violently severed by Tomura.

He stared harder and begged for it to be a mistake.

But it wasn't. That was Izuku's handwriting—but that wasn't *his*. Sitting next to Izuku's, was a crude copy of his signature. It wasn't even correct. The B was too big, and the I had been dotted. But it didn't matter. It was close enough to pass.

Katsuki felt violated.

But above all—he became fucking *wrathful*.

Izuku shook his head, tears streaking down his face as he cried through the gag. He screamed '*no*' with everything he had. The sound was muffled and breaking as his heart shattered in real time.

Katsuki steadied himself through the heartbreak. He couldn't look away from the mess of pages strewn across the snow. His whole body trembled with the quiet, soul-deep realization of what had just been stolen from them.

Their eyes met, and Katsuki's skin went cold.

This was it.

Katsuki hollowed from the inside out, accepting what was coming.

Tomura turned to Katsuki then. The white coat around his frame snapped in the wind like a banner of death as he cocked his gun.

Izuku erupted. He kicked, thrashed, and screamed into the gag with his whole soul. The sheer desperation pushed him beyond the paralytic in his veins, sending his body into convulsions. The two Yakuza restraining him had to force him to the ground. They shoved him down as his knees buckled and his chin struck the dirt.

His face hit the snow, but still he screamed.

Katsuki swallowed thickly as Tomura leveled the gun at his chest.

His throat bobbed. His lungs constricted. He flicked his gaze to Izuku, then back to the barrel aimed at him. He tried not to flinch and not to cry. But it came out anyway. Despite himself, his lip trembled and a single tear slipped past his blood-smeared lashes.

"Don't cry," Katsuki tried to soothe.

Izuku's screams grew louder but Katsuki nodded, trying to convince him that it was going to be okay. Katsuki's nose flared as he took a deep breath, never letting go of Izuku's gaze.

Katsuki braced himself for what was to come. He began counting down in his head.

"I told you—even in death, Izuku. I'll claw my way back to you again and ag—"

The gunshot cracked like thunder, cleaving the world in half.

Izuku's scream tore his throat to ribbons at the exact moment the bullet punched through Katsuki's abdomen. The impact exploded through his body in a searing burst of agony. Blood sprayed in a vivid, violent arc, splattering on the white snow.

Katsuki staggered. His eyes flew wide as the wind was knocked from him. He toppled backward into the waiting coffin with a sickening thud.

The wood groaned beneath his weight. He choked out a gasp that turned to a gurgle as pain overtook him. His hands scrambled weakly against the inside of the box. Blood began

dripping from his core as his gut burned and his vision scattered with blinding white spots.

Before he could even process the enormity of the moment, the Vipers picked up the lid of the coffin.

It was slammed down with brutal force, sealing him inside.

Darkness devoured him and terror clung to his skin.

“Nail him in tightly,” Tomura’s muffled voice instructed. “Chisaki has specific orders that he’s buried alive. The heir wants him to suffer in agony up until his last breath.”

From inside the coffin, Katsuki could still hear Izuku’s sobs.

Then the hammering began.

Each nail driven into the coffin was a scream in his ears. Every strike was like a drumbeat of torment, all orchestrated by the two men who had essentially ruined his life. The coffin rattled with every blow, and Katsuki gritted his teeth. He helplessly pressed his blood-slicked hand to his stomach, shuddering against the pain.

Outside, the Vipers dragged the coffin across the snow.

Ice cracked beneath them as they heaved it over the edge. Katsuki winced as he was jostled around. All his cuts and the fresh new bullet wound pulsated with punishing pain.

Then he felt them pick up the coffin and drop it down the grave.

He screamed on the impact as his body bounced. The pain became mind numbing. He tried to push his hand more in the wound to apply pressure. But it was pointless. His fingers trembled as he bit down his bottom lip until it tore.

Next, he heard the horrific sound of the dirt raining down on him.

Heave after heave, soil hit the coffin.

And with every layer piled on, Izuku’s crying grew more distant. The sound of the world grew muffled until he heard nothing at all. All that accompanied him was the hiss of his breath and the pounding beat of his heart. His eyes darted around in the pitch-black, looking for something and getting nothing.

He strained to hear some sort of sound—but he was entirely cut off from the land of the living.

The coffin creaked as he shifted. He laid there, stunned in pain for a long moment.

Then his breath hitched in panic. He had never been trapped like this before. He was buried alive, bleeding, and suddenly the sheer horror of it slammed into him like a freight train. The limited air was laughing at the futility of his heartbeat. He tried to recall if Aizawa trained them for a situation like this. But he drew a large, dire, blank.

His heart rate spiked in fear.

It was only a matter of time before he ran out of air.

As he felt the count down to his death, all the events rushed into him. He saw the cruelty of Tomura at the same time the broken look inside of Izuku's eyes haunted him.

He laid still, entirely paralyzed. For a moment he thought he had died already. Because there was nothing but the stale scent of his own sweat mixed with the iron tang of his insides. That smell spread and he wondered if he was really rotting away slowly in the dark.

But no, he was alive.

He was alive, running down the clock to suffocation, and he could feel every single goddamn ounce of his volatile emotions.

They rose, then collapsed.

Sadness. Fury. Hurt. Regret. Fear.

Each one took their turn swinging at him. And each one landed a punch exactly where it hurt.

He screwed his eyes shut as he cried in pain.

But he wasn't crying from his physical pain. He was crying from his heart break.

The agony from the bullet wound was nothing compared to the hurt in his heart. It was harrowing having to watch Izuku's expression crumble when he was told about the deal. The truth was wrenched out of his hands before he ever had the chance to offer it willingly—and he hated himself for it.

He had waited too long. Why did he wait so long?

Suddenly, every regret he ever had in his twenty five years piled up. The air began to thin, and his wound started bleeding more profusely.

This was really the end for him.

Katsuki's body shook with a loud sob.

As his eyes stayed shut, the world behind his lids showed him everything he lost: He saw his father. Then he saw his mother. He saw Aizawa and all his friends. Then he saw Izuku, happy and smiling. But then he saw divorce papers.

And suddenly, he saw Tomura.

Katsuki's sobs slowed, and his eyes opened.

Panic pulsed through him, and all his spiraling thoughts halted.

Tomura had Izuku. And if Katsuki didn't do something, then his lover would be lost again. But this time, possibly forever through the binding contract of marriage to the Yakuza Heir.

Fear washed over Katsuki. It showed him Izuku walking down an aisle like a lamb to slaughter. Then his fear showed him Izuku under Chisaki's thumb, wearing a ring that wasn't his.

And that was what kicked him in gear.

That possibility.

That *fate*.

"No," Katsuki rasped, voice shaking. The word dragged itself through his chest. And then it became louder, stronger, sharper—"*No*. That's not going to fucking happen."

The word fate burned in his head.

All Katsuki felt was utter compulsion to get to Izuku before it was too late. This new flame inside of him burned brighter. It seared so hot that the flame transformed from red, to blue, then pure blinding white. It burned down all the old parts of him that were dead set on revenge. And from those ashes sprouted the wings of the new man he was.

With his breath trembling and fingers slicked in blood, Katsuki twisted his arms.

The pain came fast. It was white-hot and nauseating as the shredded flesh of his wrists scraped against the too-tight zip ties. He bared his teeth like an animal as he continued to twist. He wrenched harder, biting down on his tongue, and ignored the scream building in his throat as his wrists burned like fire.

And then, with a savage jerk, the tie snapped.

The yell he let out was hoarse and broken.

He pressed his palms to the roof of the coffin, feeling the rough grain of the wood under his trembling fingertips. For a moment, he calmed his thoughts to focus. Katsuki carefully slowed his breathing, and controlled his oxygen intake.

His nostril flared as he calcified his sadness down to rage.

"You've made it this far for a reason," bellowed his fierceness.

"You're not some rookie anymore," roared his instinct, sharp and clear.

"And he's not leaving your side *ever* again," growled his anger.

His wrath reminded him who he was.

He was Bakugou fucking Katsuki who stood in the face of death time and time again, and swung on sight. He never submitted so easily to the grim reaper before. And he'd be damned

if he didn't go down swinging yet again.

He began to punch.

With every hit, a memory came.

The first blow, he saw Izuku laughing in the rain that day in Biei. His curls were slicked to his forehead, and his eyes were glowing with the kind of joy that made the world stop spinning.

The second punch brought the quiet memory of Izuku curled against his chest after a nightmare. His voice was quiet as he whispered, "I feel safe with you," so soft Katsuki had to hold his breath just to catch it.

Another punch, and there was Izuku in the grocery aisle. He was clutching a box of instant ramen like it was treasure, smiling with all his teeth.

Then more images came as he began striking in rapid succession.

Izuku in his arms, whispering that no one had ever looked at him the way Katsuki did. Izuku running barefoot through the garden at the estate, leaves brushing his ankles and sunlight tangled in his hair. Izuku leaning up to steal a kiss, his lips featherlight and loving. Izuku tangled in a blanket on their couch, warm and drowsy.

The wood began to crack.

It was small, but it gave a sliver of hope for him to sink his teeth into.

Katsuki barred a vicious snarl. His expression darkened and he punched up harder.

Splinters bit into his knuckles and he felt warm blood streamed down his forearms. But he didn't stop, not even when his bones felt like they might break.

He yelled as he drove up with everything he had.

He punched harder, and faster.

He saw Izuku laughing with Aizawa about a book they both loved. He did it again and saw Izuku shuffling across the cabin floor in socks too big for his feet. He saw Izuku pressing his face against the window to watch the snowfall like it was magic. Izuku humming softly, almost to himself, as his fingers absentmindedly combed through Katsuki's hair.

And then—one last image.

It was so clear it stole the breath from his lungs.

Izuku, standing under the yellow kitchen light, nervous and soft. He was twisting the new wedding ring around his finger as he whispered, "I'm so happy we found each other again, Kacchan."

Katsuki roared, slamming one final punch into the splintering wood.

It broke clean.

Icy air rushed in like the first gasp after drowning. Then dirt spilled down in a choking wave, heavy and cold. It swallowed his chest and mouth as he forced the jagged gap wider. His hands shook and cut on the wood. The pain in his abdomen screamed. It was a ripping sensation that clawed up his spine and down his thighs, but he kept pushing.

He was held aloft by one word that anchored him through the agony—fate.

He clawed at the dirt with ragged, ruined fingers. He dragged the soil into the coffin with frantic motions, choking on earth and breathless terror. But he pushed. He dug. His fingers slipped through the dense weight of earth, trembling and desperate.

His body began scraping upward through the tunnel he carved by sheer force of will. The soil pressed in on him, flooding his mouth and nose. His vision was still blacked out, but he didn't stop. Not even when his lungs burned and his muscles spasmed.

He kept crawling. He kept clawing.

And then—his hand broke through the topsoil.

Snow and wind exploded around the bloodied flesh that reached from the earth like vengeance itself.

A second hand followed, trembling but unstoppable. Then it was followed by one elbow, and then the next. He dragged himself up, inch by agonizing inch. His sharp teeth were bared and his body was weighed down in blood, filth, and sweat that clung to him. His wound throbbed like a second heartbeat the whole way. It spilled fresh blood with every heave, but he pushed past every ounce of pain.

His back groaned with effort. His knees dug into the frozen dirt. His hands dragged his mangled body forward until his shoulders cleared the grave. Then his chest. Then his feet. The snow stung his skin and he snarled through his clenched teeth.

When he finally collapsed onto the frozen ground beside the open grave, his chest hit the snow with an earned, exhausted thud.

He gasped. A ragged, breath ripped from his throat.

Air had never tasted so alive to him. He blinked rapidly as his heart spun out of control.

He shakily looked up across the graveyard and found no one was there. Then he looked down, trembling as he dangerously registered the amount of blood he lost—or rather, was losing.

Katsuki's fingers dug into the freezing snow.

He turned his head towards the path back to the estate and began to crawl.

☽ ☽ ☽

Every inch of his body screamed with mind numbing pain.

But he dragged himself across the snow-soaked garden of his family's estate. Along the way, he left behind a streak of scarlet that marks a brutal line between death and survival.

His limbs trembled under the weight of what he'd endured. But adrenaline vibrated through his veins like wildfire, burning away any hesitation and fear.

The estate loomed in front of him, dark and cold. He clawed his way to the back entrance, hands scrabbling against the old wooden steps. The world tilted sideways. His vision was nothing but a haze of white and red now, and lightheadedness was closing in.

He grabbed the doorknob and twisted. He groaned when it didn't budge, and hauled himself up by the door handle.

Then he reeled back and threw his shoulder into it with a guttural roar.

The wood cracked beneath him as the door splintered inward. He stumbled through, hitting the floor hard with a rattling groan. Dots danced across his vision, giving him the count down that he was going to pass out.

Katsuki tried to move, but he couldn't breathe.

His vision spun and black bloomed at the edges.

He dug his fingers into the floorboards and dragged himself forwards. He pushed through the hallway, scraping past walls that once held his mother's photos. The pain in his abdomen pulsed with every movement, red hot and wet.

He crawled through the wreckage of the house, his blood marking every floorboard, until he reached the kitchen.

With trembling fingers, he reached up and yanked himself onto the counter, gripping the edge like he was holding on to a raft in a stormy sea. The gas stove loomed above him, and he turned the knob with a shaky hand.

The flame burned steady and blue.

He fumbled toward the silverware drawer. He pulled it open and grabbed the first spoon he could find. His hands were barely working.

Carefully, he held the utensil over the flame.

The metal turned red slowly, making the seconds drag like hours.

Katsuki could barely sit upright, but he forced himself to strip off his ruined coat. He pulled off his shirt. Blood was everywhere, smeared across his body. When he exposed the abdominal gunshot, he almost threw up.

He didn’t give himself time to think too long.

He shoved his torn shirt into his mouth, bit down hard, and reached for the glowing spoon.

And then he pressed the searing metal to his wound.

The pain was immediate and catastrophic. He screamed into the gag, high and feral. The sound vibrated in his skull. The stench of burning flesh filled the kitchen as he held the spoon in place. He cursed himself repeatedly as his whole body convulsed. His hands trembled violently as he turned the spoon and pressed it to the exit wound on his back.

He choked on the scream this time.

Tears streamed from his eyes, mixing with the grime on his face. The pain was a tidal wave and he was barely keeping his head above the surface.

His vision flickered. Everything went gray, then black, then back again.

He nearly collapsed, nearly passed out right there on the tile.

Katsuki’s body slumped against the counter, skin clammy and cold. His chest heaved as if it were the only thing tethering him to the world. But then his vision blurred again. He wearily felt himself going. The colors smeared and the edges of the kitchen were darkening, spinning out of focus like ink dropped in water.

His head lolled.

Then he caught on the old beige landline mounted on the far wall by the pantry.

Katsuki groaned and forced his body forward.

He dragged himself across the tile, each movement was tormenting. His blood left slick handprints behind him. His vision blacked out once, making him hit the floor with a breathless grunt.

The world went momentarily silent.

But when it came back, he pushed harder. Crawled. Clawed. Reached.

His fingers found the edge of the wall, then the coiled phone cord.

He pulled himself upright just enough to reach the receiver, nearly dropping it as it came free. He blinked hard to stay conscious and pressed the numbers slowly, one by one. The buttons clicked beneath his trembling fingers.

He dialed the one person’s number he knew by heart.

The call rang once.

Then twice.

Then a voice crackled to life on the other end, instantly alert.

“Katsuki?!” Aizawa yelled, fully panicked. “Why are you calling from your estate? We’ve been waiting here at the rendezvous point for hours. Everyone else is here—what the hell happened—”

Katsuki opened his mouth, but nothing came out at first.

He clenched his jaw and tried again. He poured the last of his strength into the one word that mattered.

“Help,” he rasped. A broken whisper clawed its way up his throat. “Th…They took him.”

Then Katsuki’s grip slipped.

The phone hit the wall and swung limply on its cord as he collapsed in a heap. His body folded in on itself like a dying flame. His eyes fluttered, finally losing the fight. His world turned black as his blood spread quietly beneath him.

The only sound left was the soft creak of the swinging receiver and Aizawa’s distant voice yelling his name.

Chapter End Notes

Someone commented last chapter that Katsuki could excuse being buried alive but drew the line at divorce, and that is EXACTLY his energy in this fic lol this man will never willingly sign divorce papers.

Please let me know what you think below!! I hope you all have a great rest of your day :')

Chapter 43: Sordino

Chapter Summary

Sordino (Music indication) — Tells a musician to use a mute.

Chapter Notes

Hiii y'all!! :') I hope you're having a great day, here's another chapter for you!

Small note, next update will be some time in August. I have to take a short hiatus for work that's due the first week of august so I have to lock down for the next few weeks. After that is done, I will be back :')

Big thank you to the LOML, Luna, for betaing like always!!

I hope you enjoy!! 💜

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 43 — Sordino

.

.

.

He didn't know how long he was out for.

But when the door slammed open somewhere across the house, Katsuki flinched like a hunted animal. The impact vibrated through the floorboards and he could hear the hectic, scattered running of boots spill into the house. Distant shouting from familiar voices echoed down the hall, overlapping, urgent and panicked.

"Check the bedrooms!"

"I've got nothing over here—"

"Basement's empty!"

Then—

“Kitchen! He’s in here!” He heard Denki scream.

Katsuki tried to lift his head for help. But it lolled back against the floor beneath him. His body refused to listen and his vision was blinking in and out. But he could feel the chaos build. Shoes scraped against tile. Someone was shouting his name, trying to get him to respond. But he didn’t. He could only wheeze.

Now, hands were suddenly on him, pulling and frantic.

“Bakugou, can you hear me?!” He heard someone say.

But he couldn’t see them. Darkness came for him again and this time, he awoke to a sharp sting in his core. He looked down and saw red. So much red.

“He’s out of it,” Aizawa’s voice hissed. “He’s lost too much blood. Quickly, we need to get him fluids and treat this wound.”

“Holy shit, he cauterized himself.”

“He’s barely conscious,” someone else said, kneeling beside him. They reached down and checked his pulse with quick precision. “Shit. It’s thready, but holding.”

“—I’ve got the gauze, we need to hurry.”

“Get him on the table,” Aizawa ordered.

Katsuki groaned in pain as multiple people hauled him upright. Someone swiped off everything on the kitchen table that was last set how he and Izuku left it, months ago. They pulled him onto the surface underneath the single light of the room.

The pain in his gut flared again, stealing the breath from his lungs. Blood smeared beneath him, sticky and warm. His bloody, bruised hands trembled uncontrollably.

He barely registered Miruko’s voice by his ear.

“You’re alright,” she comforted. “We’ve got you. You’re alright.”

“Izuku,” Katsuki rasped. “They—he’s gone—he’s—”

“We know,” Aizawa said somewhere to his right. “Don’t worry, we’ll get him back. But you need to focus and hold on right now. You lost a lot of blood.”

“Shit—he’s burning up.”

“That’s from the cauterization,” Monoma hissed. “He’s probably in shock.”

Someone ripped open a bottle of water with their teeth and poured a capful over his lips. “Hey. Hey, Bakugou. You hang in there. You don’t get to die and leave us behind, you hear me?”

Katsuki choked on the water, coughing violently. “I—need to get to him—Izu…”

“You will,” Shinsou replied, voice surprisingly loud. “But not like this.”

Someone peeled back the fabric around the makeshift cauterization.

“It’s messy, but it’s keeping him alive,” Aizawa shouted. “We’ll clean it, stabilize him, then move him.”

Katsuki’s head fell to the side. He caught a glimpse of the emerald ring still on his finger. A sob shuddered from his chest and his eyes glazed over with tears.

“He’s not safe,” Katsuki wept.

“We know,” Aizawa repeated, gripping Katsuki’s shoulder. “And we’re gonna fix that.”

His vision came back for a moment. He looked around and surrounding him was his team. They were all bruised and bandaged up. But they all wore looks of ghostly worry, staring down at him.

Denki pressed more gauze into his wound. Sero braced Katsuki’s legs, keeping him still when he convulsed. Miruko stayed at his head, smoothing back his hair with surprising gentleness as Monoma administered a painkiller and Shinsou began prepping an emergency IV.

“We’ve got you,” Miruko comforted softly.

Katsuki blinked once. Then again, slower.

Soon, he slipped under completely.

☽ ☽ ☽

When Katsuki woke up, his entire body felt like it had been dipped in static.

Not pain exactly, but rather the numb, humming echo of it. A thick fog of painkillers clung to his flesh and bones, making everything feel far away. He blinked slowly and his vision swam until it finally focused enough to take in his surroundings.

He was in the master bedroom, laying in the bed. The afternoon sun filtered in through sheer curtains, casting golden slants across the sheets. Above him, a clear IV bag hung from the crooked top of the bedpost. And his body was wrapped in thick, white bandages. He felt twice as heavy beneath its layers. His stomach was tightly wrapped and blood seeped out faintly through the gauze.

But his hands were shredded beyond recognition. Every finger was bonded and stiff.

He tried to move. But his appendages barely twitched.

When he looked around fully, the first thing he saw was Denki. His friend was sitting at the edge of the bed, teary eyed and slumped.

When Katsuki called out for him, Denki jolted upright and whipped his head.

“He’s awake!” Denki shouted.

The room came alive in an instant.

Miruko whirled around from her spot by the window, her face crumpling with visible relief. She strode over in two quick steps, crouching by the bed to check his pulse.

At the same time, Monoma let out a long, rugged exhale and pinched the bridge of his nose. Beside him Sero leaned back against the wall with his eyes closed, his mouth whispering a soft, grateful curse under his breath. And Shinsou, who’d been seated silently in the corner, looked up and his eyes softened fully.

Then finally Aizawa, who was already beside him with a chair, leaned forward slowly.

“You okay, kid?” Aizawa asked quietly.

Katsuki shook his head weakly. “No.”

“What the hell happened?” Monoma asked, his tone gentler than ever. “How did you end up back here?”

“Tomura,” Katsuki rasped. His throat felt scorched. “He caught up to us somehow and took Izuku. Then he shot me, and buried me alive in the fucking graveyard behind the estate.”

The silence that followed was full of building anger. One by one, everyone’s expressions darkened. Miruko closed her eyes with a quiet inhale. Monoma looked away, jaw clenched. Sero pushed off the wall and began to pace.

Aizawa however, sat up slightly and looked over his shoulder, paranoid.

“How the hell did you survive?” Sero asked wearily.

“This crazy idiot punched his way out,” Shinsou answered. “That’s why your hands are so torn up, right?”

Katsuki nodded faintly.

“Shit, man…” Sero exhaled, raking a hand through his hair. “You clawed your way out of a goddamn coffin?”

Aizawa’s head suddenly snapped up.

“We need to get out of here,” he announced firmly, rising to his feet. His voice had the sharpness of urgency now, cutting through the weight of the room. “If they think Katsuki’s dead, it’ll give us an upper hand. But it’s only a matter of time before he sends someone back to check that Katsuki’s *actually* dead. We need to put a body in that grave before that happens.”

He turned to Sero with a hardened gaze. “We need your worst magic. Do you think you can stage it?”

“Yeah.” Sero straightened and nodded. “I can make it look like he bled out and suffocated. I’ll just need a body that’s the same height and build—and a coffin.”

“I can help scan morgue records in the vicinity,” Denki offered quickly, already reaching for his tablet. “It’ll go faster with two people cross-referencing.”

“Good. Get on it,” Aizawa ordered.

“We’ll need to clean up the blood trail too,” Miruko said, scanning the smeared red marks on the floorboards. “I’ll start clearing the path.”

“I’ll help clean up too,” Monoma added.

“We need to be gone in two hours,” Aizawa stated firmly. “Everyone set your watches. After we’re done here, we’re heading back to Nemuro for the rendezvous point at The Company’s satellite HQ. We have to move fast and quiet. And Katsuki,” he glancing down again, “Rest up while you can.”

Katsuki nodded, even though his chest hurt.

☽ ☽ ☽

Sero finally got his moment to shine, putting his morbid talents to work in real time.

Katsuki had seen flashes of this over the years, but he’d never bothered to pry. Sero’s resourcefulness and his unnerving knack for acquiring bodies was fucking insane. But it was exactly why Aizawa hired him to stage scenes.

But even though he knew what the guy was capable of, Katsuki couldn’t suppress the chill that moved down his spine when Sero returned with a corpse that looked eerily close to him.

It wasn’t an exact match. The man was around thirty, with mildly darker blond hair and strange orange eyes. But he was the right build, the right height, and more importantly, he’d died quietly in his sleep from an aneurysm two days prior.

Sero handled the rest with precision.

He secured a fresh coffin. Then he doctored the body with just enough blood, bruises, and dressed it in Katsuki’s clothes. He shot the corpse through the stomach and placed the man face down in blood with zip-ties binding his wrists. Then he got the whole thing buried.

After that, the rest of the team helped re-fill the grave and discreetly dispose of the shattered coffin. They scrubbed every trace of blood from the surrounding snow and soil.

By the time cleanup was done, Katsuki regained some strength. He put on new clothes that were in his closet and hobbled his way through the estate. He was leaning hard on Izuku’s old crutches, which had been tossed aside and nearly forgotten in the living room.

When he stepped outside, the cold stung his cheeks and lungs. Everyone was out in the gravesite, working hard to make sure not a single drop of blood or disturbed patch of dirt gave anything away.

He paused when he saw the scene.

It was surreal.

His grave sat right beside his mother's, clean and undisturbed. From a distance, it looked like he never escaped. It was as if Bakugou Katsuki died in that coffin, right beside his mother.

Monoma walked up next to him and lightly patted his shoulder.

"Congratulations," Monoma said. "You're officially a dead man."

☽ ☽ ☽

When they reached the satellite HQ, Katsuki took a second round of high-strength painkillers. The drugs dulled the edge of his wounds, but they couldn't mend the ache in his chest.

Several dozen other Company agents were staring with wide eyes as they burst through the halls. Shinsou and Monoma held him up on either side while Aizawa yelled for someone to go find more medical supplies.

They spilled into a stark, functional room. It was part command center and part makeshift shelter. There was a long metal conference table in the middle and a beat-up blue futon in the corner. And along the walls were several super computers and surveillance equipment.

The first thing the team did was get him down onto the futon. They layered him with blankets and fresh bandages, replacing the soaked ones from the drive. Sero handed him water and Monoma else adjusted the IV drip again.

All the while, Katsuki remained silent.

His mouth was tight with pain. And in his head, the lingering aftershock of everything that occurred rang out again and again.

Everyone kept telling him to close his eyes to try and sleep. But every time his lids drifted shut, all he could see were fragmented flashes of the night's events. The chaos of the mountain ambush. The divorce papers. The coffin closed above him. Dirt pouring down like rain. And worst of all, the expression on Izuku's face.

He re-lived how Izuku broke down, over and over.

"First things first," Aizawa announced loudly, eyes already scanning the map projected on one of the large flat screens. "Kaminari, do you think you can pull up any leads? We should start in Tokyo and fan out from there—"

"I put a tracker in his ring," Katsuki admitted.

The room went silent. Then everyone turned slowly. Their faces shifted from stunned to impressed then to something shy of horrified. Only Monoma didn't react. He simply pressed his lips together and looked off to the side as if he wasn't an accomplice.

Aizawa's brows shot up. "You *what*?"

Katsuki winced. "Right before the ambush, I welded a tracker inside his ring. I didn't get a chance to tell him—I just...I needed to know I could find him if something happened. Denki, I can give you my passwords. You should be able to access my cloud and sync the signal to your system."

"Perfect," Denki exclaimed immediately, already pulling out his laptop. "Man, I am *so* glad you're paranoid. That's the kind of crazy that saves lives."

Katsuki gave the barest nod. "We have to find him before it's time to—"

And then it hit him.

Nana.

He jolted upright. Pain spiked through his abdomen, but he was too panicked to give it notice. He stumbled forward, desperate, lungs working too hard.

"W-We—" Katsuki broke into a violent cough, clutching his stomach. "Someone has to find Nana! We have to tell her what happened and ask if she can wait. We need to buy more time."

The team exchanged tense glances. Aizawa immediately began running through logistics in his head.

"I'll go," Shinsou volunteered without hesitation. He squared his shoulders, already rising to his feet. "Do you know her location?"

"Not exactly," Katsuki admitted, voice thin. "But I know enough to get you started. Her code phrase is 'One for All.' Izuku said she's using an anagram, 'Lone Flora.' She's probably staying in a hideaway under that name. It would be some kind of discreet business, maybe a pub."

"I'll go too," Miruko added firmly. "We'll take turns driving and push through the night."

Katsuki nodded, forcing himself to focus. He scribbled down everything he could remember from the black folder. He wrote down addresses, names, contacts, and every description that he could recall from when he'd done his intense research on the matter. He handed the list to Shinsou and Miruko as they prepared to leave.

Then he jotted down access codes and system credentials for Denki and Sero so they could tap into the tracker. They moved fast and jumped off to the computers on the other side of the room. Their fingers began typing faster than Katsuki could even think.

Within minutes, Shinsou and Miruko tore out the door.

The silence afterward was heavy.

Aizawa went outside the room and came back with food for everyone. He set down a bowl of broth and handed it to Katsuki, who could barely hold the spoon. Monoma took a bowl of soup and began to eat. As he did, he periodically adjusted Katsuki's IV bag and administered more pain killers.

"We'll find him," Aizawa whispered, eyes tired but steady.

Katsuki couldn't answer.

Because deep down, he didn't know if that was true.

The pressure bearing down on him now felt worse than being trapped in that coffin.

☽ ☽ ᔓ ☾ ☾

Izuku couldn't feel his legs.

He wasn't sure if it was from his injuries or the aftershock. Everything inside him felt sluggish and warped.

It felt like he was being held underwater. Every breath he sucked in was thick. Every step he heard was too far away. He didn't feel like he was in his body. Not really. His mind was stuck at the gravesite, staring into the black headstone that read Bakugou Katsuki.

He could still hear the sound of dirt hitting the coffin. The soft thump of it repeated like the ticking of some cruel clock that was stuck.

They drove all the way back to Tokyo with Izuku tied up in the backseat.

Tomura instructed that he be put in extra restraints. But really, there was no need for that. Izuku didn't move. He didn't even talk. He stared blankly up at the car roof, remaining mute the whole, eighteen hour car ride back to Tokyo.

When they arrived at their destination, it was nearly nightfall.

Tomura dragged him out of the car without so much as a word. His brother's hand clamped around his arm like a vice as he unkindly yanked him along.

Izuku stumbled the whole way through the slush and gravel. His body ached. His ribs screamed. His lip was split—but none of it registered. It was far away, like it was happening to someone else. Behind him, the loud, synchronized footsteps of the guards kept pace. Half were Vipers. Half were Yakuza. A wall of silence and steel pressed in on him from every direction.

But he didn't fight them.

He couldn't—not now.

Not when every time he blinked, he saw Katsuki falling.

The image of blood splashing across snow kept looping in his mind. He swore he could still hear Katsuki groaning in pain through the dirt.

That wasn't real. It couldn't be real. This was wrong. Maybe it hadn't happened the way he thought. Maybe Katsuki was alive and breathing and okay. Maybe they would open the coffin and find it empty, broken open by Katsuki's indomitable strength. Maybe Izuku imagined the whole thing. Maybe this was all a dream, and they were still actually in the cabin.

Maybe.

Maybe.

Maybe.

He clung to denial like it could breathe for him.

They rounded to a large golden bridge that crossed a giant mote. In the center of the large body of water was the Chisaki family home. It rose out of the Tokyo fog like a fortress ripped from another era. It was an enormous traditional castle with sweeping tiled eaves, black lacquered beams, and walls wrapped in elegant jade motifs.

Gold shimmered across the gates, tracing ancient characters in artful brushstrokes. It was objectively beautiful, and didn't belong in the modern skyline. The Chisaki family estate was truly untouched by time, anchored in power so deep it didn't need to evolve.

They passed under the archway. Awaiting them were hundreds of guards poised in black and gold. In their hands were katanas and on their backs were rifles. They stepped aside when Tomura came into full view.

The gates opened for them like a flower blossoming.

The floors were polished mahogany, and the scent of incense and old cedar lingered faintly in the air. Tall golden statues stood at the corners of every hallway. They passed by sculptures of dragons, phoenixes, and tigers carved in exquisite detail, each somehow more menacing than the last.

Black and beige screens partitioned corridors like shadows. Their painted surfaces glinted with gold leaf patterns of beautiful flowers and crows.

Tomura kept dragging him deeper and deeper into the palace.

The doors at the end of the corridor loomed large, carved from thick ebony wood and set with gilded chrysanthemums and cranes. When they opened, they did so with ritualistic slowness, revealing the long, cavernous chamber beyond.

And waiting inside, like royalty on a throne of brutality and gold, were the Chisakis.

Chisaki Kai sat at the center of the elevated platform, spine straight, expression bored. He wore traditional clothes. His kimono was black threaded with gold designs. Obsidian beads hung around his wrist and his gloved hands were folded neatly in his lap.

To his right sat his mother.

Izuku had never seen her before, but he knew she was the beating heart of the yakuza. Her name was Chisaki Kurenai. Her hair was pinned up with dazzling hair jewelry and expensive combs. And her beauty was as perfect as ice. She was dressed in an all gold kimono, and her eyes were a deep brown exactly like her hair.

On the Heir's left was the Chisaki patriarch, Takeshi.

He was older than his wife, hair a dusted grey with black streaks. And his eyes were shining gold, like his son's. He dressed in an all black kimono, resting against a black cane that held the symbol of a crow etched into it. His eyes were sunken but sharp and his mouth was drawn in permanent disdain.

All three of them assessed Izuku.

They didn't move. They waited expectantly.

Tomura shoved him forward.

Izuku collapsed at the edge of the tatami with a weak grunt. His knees buckled from under him and his body locked up. He flexed his arms out of instinct, but they were uselessly tied behind his back.

He didn't dare to lift his head. Everything in him screamed that if he looked up, he'd lose what little was holding him together.

"Well," Chisaki Kai said finally. Izuku hated how his voice sounded so polished and perfect. "About time."

Izuku didn't answer. He lowered his head further.

"You'll have to excuse his silence," Tomura replied for him and bowed at the waist. "He's in shock."

"Ah, poor thing," cooed Chisaki Kurenai, tilting her head with pity as she leaned in slightly. Her delicate golden fan fluttered at her wrist. "How long do you think it'll take him to recover?"

"I'd give it a week or so," Tomura replied, as if discussing a common illness. "He rebounds fairly quickly, especially when left undisturbed."

Chisaki Kai exhaled heavily, as though he was the one being inconvenienced.

"And Bakugou?" he asked curtly, tone flat with impatience. "Did you bury that obnoxious bastard alive like I asked?"

“I did,” Tomura replied easily. “The job was done without an issue.”

“Good. I was beginning to get a headache.”

The conversation moved on without Izuku, even though he was its subject. He tried to pay attention, but he could barely keep himself in the moment. He stared down at the floor, blinking against the sting in his eyes. His mind was spiraling—and his heart was still somewhere beneath the snow in Biei.

When his awareness returned, the voices were closer.

“Well, let’s get a good look at him,” Takeshi sighed, slightly displeased.

Izuku tensed as they approached.

Kurenai crouched gracefully in front of him, lifted her fan beneath his chin, and gently tilted his face upward. Her touch was delicate, but it made his stomach turn. He remained silent as the three of them took in his face and all his new bruises. They tipped his head left to right, assessing him then and there like a jewel.

Kurenai looked closely at his eyes and he could see a spark of admiration.

“The bruises seem like they will fade,” she noted happily. “He really is as striking as the rumors.”

“He better be worth the trouble,” Takeshi grunted. “We’ve lost too many good men over this brat. He’s not going to throw another fit, is he?”

“His outbursts are under control,” Tomura replied smoothly. “He didn’t struggle on the way here. I’d say that’s a clear sign he’s finally learned his place. My apologies again for the casualties.”

Takeshi scoffed, face hard. “If it were my call, I’d have put him in the ground right next to that Bakugou bastard. He should consider himself *very* fortunate that Zen is a long term family friend.”

Izuku’s brow furrowed faintly.

Who was Zen?

If he wasn’t in such shock, Izuku would’ve dwelled on that more. But instead, his thoughts kept rewinding to Katsuki being shot if he even dared think of anything else.

“I, for one, am glad he’s still breathing,” Kurenai interjected lightly, as if to smooth over her husband’s disdain, “Kai has been looking forward to spending time with him more than he lets on.” She turned to her son with a knowing smile. “Isn’t that right, Kai?”

All eyes turned to the man in question. He’d been silent this whole time, watching Izuku like a vulture. He picked Izuku clean with his gaze, breaking down every inch of the man who dared defy him.

“That is right, mother,” Kai confirmed.

With a flick of his hand, he gestured for Izuku to be lifted.

Two guards moved in, hoisting Izuku roughly to his feet. His legs buckled from the strain, and pain flared in his joints, but he grit his teeth and bore it.

When he opened his eyes, sickness hit him.

Standing across from him was Chisaki Kai. His expression was a mix of his mother’s and father’s. Distaste and warped admiration. He was visibly annoyed at all the trouble Izuku went through to get away from him. But Izuku could see in his eyes, the denial made him more interested in a roundabout way.

The Yakuza heir tilted his head, and a cruel smile twitched at the edge of his mouth.

“Still as beautiful as the day you slaughtered your family,” Kai complimented.

Izuku recoiled.

Then suddenly, Kai called out, “Uraraka, bring the ankle bracelet.”

At that, Izuku’s whole body locked up. He turned and saw someone he didn’t notice before.

Coming towards him was a small woman in a plain, grey yukata. She was shorter than him, and hunched ever so slightly. She possessed medium length brown hair and chestnut eyes. Her face was rounded and rosy, but her eyes were distant. She moved like she wasn’t here mentally and in her hands was a tiny wooden box.

When she opened it, sitting inside was a delicate golden ankle cuff. It was a solid, thick metal and in the center it was embossed with the Shie Hassaikai symbol. But it also held a small blinking light on the back.

“A little insurance,” Chisaki Kai explained simply.

The woman knelt at his feet, hands trembling ever so slightly. She secured the cuff around his ankle with a muted click.

The chill of the metal hugged his skin immediately, cold and final.

ᔓᔓᔓ

The Chisakis offered them a cordial tour of the estate. Even though the civility of it all felt like a performance meant only to pat themselves on the back.

Izuku was paraded through the halls. His hands were still bound by his restraints and on all sides were armed guards and Tomura, keeping his arm in a vice grip. In front of them, the Chisaki family walked in elegant formation.

And behind them trailed the small woman, Uraraka. She kept her eyes downcast and all her movements were quiet. It was as if she were trying to become invisible.

The large group moved through corridor after corridor. Every room was more lavish than the last, but the luxury barely registered to Izuku. His mind was trapped back in Biei, frozen in time and stuck in denial. For the hundredth time, he relieved Katsuki being nailed in the coffin. He tried to rewrite the memory. He added a miraculous extension where Katsuki clawed his way free.

He had to. Right? It was Katsuki. His Kacchan was unyielding, powerful, and clever.

Izuku's eyes blurred. And behind his ribs, his heart was still beating in the dark with Katsuki. It pounded against the coffin lid, waiting to be let out.

They walked every floor of the estate, all five towering stories of it. All the while Chisaki Kurenai spoke in lilting, pleasant tones as if she was giving a tour of a cozy countryside inn. She described each wing with theatrical enthusiasm: the grand music hall that was lined with traditional shamisen and drums, the endless corridors of libraries, and the twin kitchens that smelled faintly of spices and smoke.

Every room they passed gleamed with deliberate elegance, adorned in the house's signature palette—obsidian black, deep jade, and glinting gold.

As Chisaki Kurenai went on, Izuku wondered if she noticed the dried blood on his face or the tears that still streaked his cheeks. Or perhaps, like her son, she took a quiet satisfaction in seeing him hollowed out.

Maybe to them, he really was just a wild, beautiful thing that'd finally been tamed—finally *theirs*.

Eventually, they reached the last staircase leading to the top floor.

At the very end of the corridor was an elegant, large shoji door. It was slid open by silent servants.

"And here is the last room," Kurenai announced smoothly, gesturing with a graceful hand. "Your residence for the time being."

Izuku froze in the doorway.

The color palette was entirely dark green and gold. The arrangement of furniture was nearly like his room at the Viper compound and the shelves were all lined with his favorite books and vinyl records. It was an eerie reconstruction of all the comforts he gravitated towards—and it made him sick.

"With your brother's help, I had this prepared for you a few days before the masquerade," Kai explained casually with his hands folded behind his back. "If anything isn't to your liking, let Uraraka know. We'll see to it."

“She’ll serve as your handmaiden,” Takeshi added, stepping forward with a voice that was both formal and sharp. “Her family’s debt is significant, and she’s paying it off by serving here. She’s been instructed to meet your every need—no exceptions. So if there’s something you require, do not hesitate.”

Uraraka bowed slightly then. Her hands clenched tightly around the sleeves of her samue.

“I’m afraid this is where we part for a couple of days,” Chisaki Kai huffed, a bit annoyed. “But only for a week. We weren’t sure when you would be brought here, so we scheduled a business meeting overseas. In the meantime, Izuku, please rest up and recalibrate. It’s quite late.”

“Same for you, Tomura,” Takeshi instructed. “We have a lot to discuss when I come back.”

Izuku stared at the room, and his mind ripped him back to Biei.

He kept hearing the gunshot, over and over.

It didn’t even register when the Chisakis gave their goodbyes. And he didn’t notice when the Yakuza bodyguards peeled off. Izuku only snapped back to the present when Tomura pushed him forward into the room and one of the vipers began to cut him loose.

On instinct, he brought his hands to his chest. He quietly nursed his wrists as he took a look around. Sourness bit at him. This was yet another beautiful cage he was trapped in—and this time he got a golden shackle to match.

Tomura turned his back and began discussing logistics with the remaining Vipers.

Their voices dropped to quiet murmurs as they exchanged plans for the week. But Izuku’s attention drifted downward—until it landed on his left hand.

His body jolted.

There, gleaming defiantly on his finger, was the eternity wedding band.

His breath caught in his throat. Slowly, with trembling fingers, he slipped the ring off and curled it tightly into his fist. He shielded it from view and his body began to shake from nerves. Out of fear, Izuku dared a glance toward Tomura. His brother was still talking, and then Izuku cautiously looked to the side.

He froze.

Uraraka’s gaze was fixed on him.

She saw the ring. She saw everything.

For one tense second, Izuku braced himself for her to speak. He began to prepare himself for her to expose him and call attention to it like a good, loyal Yakuza servant would do. But she didn’t. Her expression shifted a bit, mildly unreadable.

She dropped her gaze to the floor and said nothing.

“The first chance you get, go back to Biei,” Tomura suddenly instructed. “Dig up the grave and make sure the body inside is dead.”

Izuku’s head snapped up. His heart clutched.

“Understood,” one of the Vipers replied. “We’ll report back tomorrow afternoon.”

And with that, they turned on their feet with the guns. They marched out of the room with military precision.

Izuku stood frozen, his ears ringing with a single thought: they might find nothing in that coffin.

His pulse thundered so loud it nearly drowned out the quiet. If they returned and said the body was gone—if Katsuki somehow survived—then everything wasn’t lost. Katsuki would come for him, Izuku knew it.

Tomura then walked towards him and cleared his throat.

“Izuku, there’s something you should know regarding you and One,” he began gently. “It’s… the underlying reason you needed to be brought back. He’s coming tomorrow to talk to you.”

But Izuku barely heard him.

He was too busy praying that Katsuki’s grave would be empty.

“Izuku?” Tomura repeated. “Are you listening to me?”

He didn’t respond. He leaned his head down further, shadowing his eyes. He couldn’t stomach looking at his brother after what he’d done.

Tomura opened his mouth again. He hesitated, starting and stopping on a word.

If he didn’t know any better, it nearly sounded like Tomura was conflicted. His brother then shifted on his feet and exhaled roughly. He turned his back on Izuku and then walked towards the door. When he reached the exit, he turned to glance over his shoulder, quietly apprehensive.

“I’ll be back tomorrow,” Tomura murmured. “Goodnight, Izuku.”

The doors slid open then they slid shut.

The only people left now were the Yakuza guards outside his door and Uraraka who was quietly gathering a damp towel. She silently began wiping his face clean of all the dirt, sweat and blood. Izuku shut off his mind and let himself be led. She drew a bath for him and laid out a fresh set of pajamas for him on the sink.

“I will come and take you to breakfast in the morning,” she whispered, bowing slightly. “Have a good rest.”

And with that, she left Izuku alone in the bathroom. He stood there for a moment, then finally he stripped out of his dirty clothes. Izuku climbed in and hugged his knees to his chest. He sunk into the warmth and let it cradle him.

Only when Izuku knew he was alone, did he open his palm.

He cradled the ring and softly cried.

ɯɯɯ

Izuku didn’t sleep, not really. He’d spent the entire night going through every possible outcome.

Katsuki clawing his way out. Katsuki holding his breath long enough. Katsuki using brute strength to splinter the wood and punch through the dirt. Even Aizawa finding him, and digging him out in time. There were a thousand ways Izuku imagined Katsuki could’ve survived.

But there was one, more realistic way he didn’t.

And Izuku refused to believe in that one. He bargained everything he could think of, offering it to the universe as a token. If Katsuki was alive, he’d give anything. Absolutely anything.

Uraraka helped him get ready. She laid out a plain, black samue for him that was donned with decorative gold stitch work along the hems. Quietly, they were escorted down to the main dining room by two stoic guards. The golden ankle bracelet on his leg rattled with every step he took.

When they reached the grand dining hall, Izuku was ushered to the long mahogany table and seated alone.

His breakfast was already waiting. It was hot rice, miso soup, grilled fish, and pickled vegetables.

Behind him, four Yakuza guards stood quietly, monitoring him.

Instead of eating, Izuku gazed out the window. He looked across the vastness of Tokyo and waited anxiously to find out what happened to Katsuki.

As he waited, he imagined his tenacious lover barging through the doors. He could perfectly picture Katsuki breaking through multiple guards bare fists alone. Everyone would scatter and it would become a bloody brawl. Izuku almost smiled. He held out hope that Katsuki was alive. Or even better, he would come find him.

He always did. They *always* found each other.

Again and again and again.

Izuku was certain that it had to happen once more, right?

Because if his grave was unearthed and no body was found, Izuku was going to find his way out immediately and search for Katsuki.

He stayed like that, staring out of the window for however long. His food went cold and no one said anything as he held his arms closely to his body.

At some point, Izuku slipped the ring from his pocket. It was still warm from being cradled in his palm all night. The metal glinted softly in the light, delicate and eternal. He turned it in his fingers slowly, as if the act of holding it could conjure Katsuki from thin air.

He imagined his lover alive somewhere, sitting just like this. He was probably staring at his own ring and thinking of Izuku, too.

With that thought, the ache in his chest softened for a moment.

But then the doors slid open with a sharp click, and the spell shattered. His eyes darted to the side, catching Tomura stepping into the dining room. His brother was accompanied by two Vipers and he was dressed casually.

Izuku's pulse spiked.

Quickly, he closed his hand around the ring in a fist—but it was too late.

Tomura's eyes narrowed, and his steps faltered.

"What was that?" he asked, already knowing.

Izuku shook his head, eyes wide with panic. "Nothing—"

"Izuku," Tomura warned, low and sharp. He crossed the space in long, fast strides, looming over him with a glare that iced over any chance of mercy. "Give it to me."

"N-No," Izuku whispered.

He stood up and stepped back when Tomura came at him.

"Tomura, please—not this," Izuku begged, voice cracking. Tears burned hot behind his eyes.

But it didn't matter. Tomura seized his wrist.

Izuku fought to keep his fist clenched. He twisted and resisted with what little strength he had left.

"Tomura!" he cried. "*Please*! Just let me have this—*just this*!"

The pain shot up his body like fire, making his healing injuries scream in protest. But he held on anyway. He held on to the ring as if both his and Katsuki's lives depended on it. Because

in some twisted way, it did.

But Tomura was stronger—always had been.

With a snarl of frustration, he grabbed Izuku's wrist in both hands and began prying his fingers open one by one, ignoring Izuku's howls of pain. Izuku writhed in his grip, voice breaking with every desperate plea he made—until the ring slipped free.

It hit the floor with a soft, damning clink.

Tomura picked it up without a word and pocketed it like it was nothing but a trinket. His face was stone, but his sigh was low and heavy, filled with exhaustion.

Izuku fists clenched tight against his chest, trembling. He bowed his head low, his bangs casting his face in shadow. The taste of blood filled his mouth as he bit his lip to keep from sobbing.

"This is for your own good," Tomura chided, turning away.

Izuku heard that sentence too many times to believe it anymore.

He used to think Tomura was doing what was best for him. He believed that somewhere beneath all the harshness and the cruelty—there was care. He figured, maybe it was just buried under the same violence they'd both been raised in.

But now…now he wasn't so sure.

Maybe once, Tomura had been protecting him. But somewhere along the line, that instinct twisted. Now, all Izuku could see was control dressed up as care. He realized, with quiet devastation, that Tomura couldn't tell the difference anymore between what was good for him —and what was good for Izuku.

Tomura sat at the long table, visibly trying to compose himself. The cold mask slipped over his face, but not fully. There were cracks now. He looked older and tired.

Still, his voice came sharp. "Sit down."

And Izuku, as if yanked by an invisible chain, obeyed.

He lowered himself slowly into the chair, hands trembling in his lap. He tried not to cry. But his left hand ached with absence. His ring finger throbbed like an open wound and no amount of biting his tongue could soothe the rawness of it.

They sat in silence as a servant delivered Tomura's breakfast. He ate quietly, eyes on his plate, as if nothing happened. And beside him, Izuku said nothing at all.

When too much time went by Tomura turned to him with a level of apprehension.

"You should eat," Tomura advised, not unkindly. "It's been too long."

Izuku didn't answer. He turned away, pressing his lips together. His fingers curled in his lap, trembling as he fought the urge to scream.

Then Tomura leaned forward, eyes narrowing.

"What did you do to your hands?" He asked tightly.

Izuku blinked. His hands?

Before the thought could even settle, Tomura reached out and grabbed his wrist. Izuku flinched on instinct, trying to snatch his arm back, but Tomura's grip tightened. He dragged Izuku's arm upward, leveling it between them.

Both of them froze.

There, he found his thumb was angry and irritated. The skin on it had been picked raw. The wounds weren't fresh, but they were clearly new. They were infected with stress and etched from days of unconscious damage.

Izuku stared, momentarily disoriented. When had he done that?

"When did you start doing this again, Izuku?" Tomura hissed, annoyed but slightly concerned.

A long time ago, Izuku used to pick at the skin around his hands when he was a child. He didn't do it on purpose. Most of the time, he wasn't entirely aware of it. Hiryu told him it was a response to anxiety and tried to get him into meditation to help take the edge off, but it didn't really work.

Tomura noticed it shortly after.

Later, he quietly placed a stress ball on Izuku's desk.

No words were exchanged and they never discussed it. Izuku used that stress ball and he tapered off picking at his hands. He eventually didn't need it. Because the next year, he met Katsuki. And after that, he began to calm himself down by imagining lovely red eyes and blond hair.

But he supposed that small, ugly habit must've resurfaced somewhere between the masquerade and now.

Tomura sighed, barely audible. He put Izuku's hand down when he didn't get an answer and couldn't meet his eye. He looked across the way instead, staring at one of the jade dragon statues in the corner.

"One is coming to talk to you today," Tomura whispered, barely audible. His eyes skirted down with reluctance, unlike him. "He has a couple of things to discuss with you."

Izuku tensed. He closed his eyes, took a deep breath.

Of *course* One was coming.

Their leader was going to strip him down for the disgrace he'd caused. Maybe One struck some backroom deal with the Chisakis to get Izuku dragged home faster. He likely needed to do damage control before the news could spread too far that one of Viper Academy's top assassins had defected, fallen in love, murdered two dozen of their best, and freed the next cohort.

This time, Izuku felt his thumb twitch. The pain was sudden and sobering, but he stopped himself. He squeezed his hands together instead, knuckles whitening as he tried to ground himself.

Instead he tried to think of lovely red eyes and blond hair—alive.

They sat in silence for a long stretch, unmoving.

Neither of them spoke again.

One of the attendants approached and set a black teacup in front of Tomura, who took it without a word. He sipped slowly, and the two of them stared out the tall windows. The Tokyo skyline was painted in fog and morning haze.

And in that silence, Izuku thought of how much he hated his brother.

Not with the hot rage of a child, but with the cold anger of understanding. Because now—after knowing what real family, real tenderness, and real love was supposed to feel like—he could finally name what he'd never had. He'd lived his entire life in grayscale, and only now did he realize the world was meant to be painted in color.

The books hadn't lied to him.

The outside world *was* better.

It was softer. It was kind. It didn't demand blood for loyalty or obedience in exchange for survival. People out there weren't simple like he'd been taught. No. People were layered, shaped by heartache and hope. They weren't all good or all bad; they were messy, complicated—*human*.

And now that he knew that truth—Izuku wasn't sure he could ever stomach the poison of this life again.

So he held onto hope that Katsuki was alive.

Because if his books were right about the world, then they had to be right about love, too. In those stories, lovers always reunite. They broke through impossible walls, fought armies, cut through monsters and madness and dug themselves out of graves if they needed to.

Because love, true love like he and Katsuki had, made someone unstoppable.

So Izuku repeated that to himself, over and over. He did this until it became a chant louder than the silence.

And eventually, he believed it more than anything else in the world.

ᔓᔓᔓ

One requested they meet in the sunroom.

The sunroom was a glass-walled chamber nestled beside the estate's central garden. The space was quiet, serene almost, and filled with natural light that glinted off the polished stone floors. A small tea table sat in the center atop woven tatami. Surrounding it were two black cushions.

And just beyond the frost-laced windows, the garden stretched in perfect stillness.

It sat untouched with snow blanketing evergreen shrubs and curling around the black stones. In the center was a frozen pond and a pop of color of jade and gold in the sculptures that were scattered around.

The world outside looked peaceful.

But when One entered, the temperature dropped.

Izuku stiffened before he even saw him.

One glided into the room with the lethal grace of an old snake. He was dressed in a black suit so crisp it looked crafted from obsidian. His white curls were slicked back and the starkness of them brought out the contrast in his skin. Even the freckles on his face looked darker, and his crimson eyes were as expressionless as cut gems.

In one gloved hand, he carried his signature gold-plated cane with its serpent's head. The diamond eyes glinted like they knew everything Izuku's done.

And the stare One gave him—it could've carved through stone.

Izuku clenched his jaw.

"217," One greeted smoothly, voice devoid of warmth. "It's good to see you again."

Izuku didn't respond immediately. But the sheer weight of One's presence pressed against him like a hand on the back of his neck. It broke the silence he'd wrapped around himself for protection.

He bowed deeply. "It's…good to see you too, sir."

A silent attendant entered, dressed in muted gray. He poured green tea into their porcelain cups that were patterned with delicate golden cranes.

One gave a soft, vacant thank-you, then raised his cup and sipped without breaking eye contact.

“How was your brief expedition?” One asked, pointedly.

Izuku’s throat dried. He opened his mouth, tried to speak—but nothing came out. Sweat broke out beneath his sleeves.

“Speak freely,” One commanded.

He leaned in and rested his chin on his folded hands. The gesture was almost casual, but the heat behind his eyes wasn’t. It sliced through Izuku and pinned him in place.

“Go ahead. Tell me, Izuku. How did you enjoy your months of defiance?”

Izuku bowed low to the table instantly. He squeezed his eyes shut and held his breath. He prayed that One didn’t take his head right then and there—not before he found out Katsuki’s fate.

“I’m sorry, sir,” Izuku muttered, voice trembling. “I’m so very sorry.”

One scoffed. “I want to know what idiotic fantasy you’d constructed in that head of yours. Where did you think you could run? Hah? Who would take in a thing like you?” His tone turned venomous. “You weren’t planning another Hiryu disaster, were you? You’re smarter than to repeat such stupidity.”

“I…” Izuku swallowed, voice raw. “I was going to leave the country.”

“To where?”

“Anywhere,” he admitted, voice shrinking.

One stared at him like he was filth.

“You really are a goddamn *child*.”

His hand slammed the table. The cups jumped, tea sloshed. Izuku didn’t flinch—but only because he braced for it.

“I’m deeply disappointed in you,” One hissed, every syllable sharp enough to cut down to the bone. “You’ve cost me more money than you’re worth, and Tomura has wasted countless hours cleaning up the wreckage you left behind. Do you have any idea the kind of disgrace you’ve brought to me? To the Academy?”

Izuku pressed his lips in a thin line.

“Tell me,” One pressed. “Where did you take the kids? We’ve been trying to locate them or their families but we are unable to.”

"…I gave them back to their parents," Izuku admitted, steeling himself a bit. "And then I helped them disappear so they would be safe from us."

He dared to look One in the eye then. He was scared, but he wasn't sorry. Of all the things Izuku's done, this was one he was willing to stand behind fully. He would never regret saving those kids lives, not even if it meant getting slapped brutally across the face.

One grew colder. He straightened his spine and their gazes clashed for a vicious moment.

Izuku could see One's fist curl, as if preparing to strike.

He readied himself for it—but it never came.

"If you weren't *you*," One growled slowly, "I would've dragged your body back in pieces and strung your head up as an example for everyone to see. You've broken my laws. You've stained *my* name. You should be dead."

"I'm sorry," Izuku said through his clenched jaw.

"You're not," One snarled. "I can see it in your eyes. But it's okay. You are already dead to me."

A silence followed. It was overpoweringly chilling and suffocating.

"But tell me," he jeered, voice low. "Have you learned your lesson?"

"…I have, sir," Izuku replied, voice nearly gone.

One narrowed his eyes, examining him.

"Don't lie to me. If even one ember of rebellion is still burning in your mind—if you even think of disobedience again—speak, so I can put it out permanently right now."

Izuku hesitated. He thought of scarlet eyes and golden hair. Then he thought of a grave that may or may not be empty.

"I've learned my lesson," he lied, fluidly. "I won't try to escape again."

One watched him for a long time. He picked him apart. Izuku wondered if One could see right through him, and sense his urge to flee. But if One noticed it, he didn't say anything. He narrowed his eyes, leaned back and shook his head like he was disgusted.

"Tomura blames that Bakugou boy for corrupting you," One said. His voice turned contemplative, but no warmer. "He thinks it was love that turned your head. I am unsure if I believe that. But I suppose we'll find out now that that Bakugou boy is…gone."

Izuku clenched his fists.

"You had so much potential," One continued. "All that brilliance—wasted. Thrown away because you got caught up in something as weak and foolish as *feelings*."

Izuku muttered another apology, barely audible.

He sealed his emotions away behind walls he hadn't touched in months. It'd been so long since he needed to repress his emotions. Katsuki taught him what it was like to feel something real, and just be human.

But Izuku reverted at that moment, for Katsuki's sake. Because if there was even the faintest chance that his lover was still alive, Izuku was going to run as fast as possible to find him.

So he needed to survive this.

"I'm going to be entirely transparent," One stated suddenly. "Chisaki is not the only one who wanted you brought back home. I did as well. I helped push forward the mission to get you back."

Izuku kept his expression neutral and took a careful sip of tea.

"Why, sir?" he asked, throat tight.

"Do you remember what I said before I sent you to eliminate Peter Moore?" One asked, swirling the tea in his cup.

"Vaguely, sir."

"I mentioned your hair color." He nodded slightly toward Izuku's curls. "The dark green, it's very unique. I've only ever seen it one time before in my life, and it made me think curiously about you having it. After you left, I looked at your file."

He paused, setting down his tea with a faint clink.

"I don't normally concern myself with the files of every child dragged through our system. That's beneath my station. But something…pulled at me. And when I read your records, I saw her name. There's no delicate way to say this. Your mother and I…we knew each other."

Izuku's breath slowed.

Time suspended in the air and Izuku's fingers tightened around his cup.

"After I saw that," One sighed. "I asked Tomura to get one of your hair brushes and I pulled a strand out. Then I ran your hair against mine."

One looked at Izuku directly now, his gaze sharpened.

"We're a match," One said.

Izuku leaned back.

His back straightened involuntarily, spine locking into place as though something cracked down the center of his chest. He couldn't feel the floor beneath him. The air turned thin. His

thoughts scattered and scrambled for something solid to hold onto. But the conversation turned into a straight vertical drop, and he was free falling.

"…What?" he whispered.

But One's expression barely changed.

"Don't make me repeat it," he said coldly. "I didn't know she was pregnant. If I had, I would've tracked her down the moment she disappeared."

Izuku reeled.

His lips parted, but no sound emerged. Only a faint, fractured echo of his breath catching in his throat came out. The walls of the sunroom tilted, warped by the sudden shift in gravity as the truth crashed through him.

His heartbeat surged, deafening him. His lungs forgot how to work.

He looked at One's features—not one. His father? He looked at his father's features. The curly white hair. The red eyes.

The freckles.

Izuku soaked in the information the longer he counted One's freckles. Then he began to recall Inko's features. He overlaid them on each other and became progressively queasy when they perfectly melted together to—

Make him.

"Cruel how life works sometimes," One bitterly mused, leaning back. "I always wanted a biological son. But no one ever matched your mother's beauty to bear my children. So I gave up. I took Tomura under my wing instead—he was driven, and in need of guidance. But you…" He smiled reluctantly. "You were under my roof this whole time, and I didn't know."

Then it hit Izuku: the violent, ugly reason why Inko gave him up in the first place.

He recoiled in fear, disgust, and horror.

If One caught the change in his demeanor, he didn't seem to care. Instead his eyes danced across Izuku's face. His tone softened with something that might've passed for nostalgia if it hadn't sounded so icy.

"I feel foolish," One murmured. "Now that I really look at you, you're the spitting image of Inko when she was your age. You have her heart shaped face and her honey kissed skin. You even have the exact bright eyes and dark hair that allured me to her in the first place. Her beauty captured my attention the same way yours has captured Chisaki Kai's."

Izuku wanted to scream, but he couldn't.

He was feeling too many emotions. They piled on top of each other, weighing him down. It became so much to the point all the things he was feeling began to cancel each other out in a numbing, static sensation.

“I suppose this is karma, in an ironic way,” One continued. “My own son, subjected to trafficking under my nose this whole time. And worse—he is somehow both reckless and *stupid*.”

The energy shifted.

Suddenly a deep look of sourness was being tossed his way.

“Your stunts have cost us a lot,” One growled in a low, threatening tone. “Over several dozen clients pulled their funding and their assignments because you murdered all our top assassins. The financial distress you have placed on my shoulders is considerable. If you weren’t my own blood, I would have ordered to have you beheaded, just like Nine. Do you have any idea how to fix this burden, Izuku?”

“…No. I’m sorry, sir,” Izuku replied quietly.

“Well I do,” One snapped. “You are going to convince Chisaki Kai to marry you.”

As if summoned by the cruelty of the moment, a cloud passed over the sun. The light dimmed. Shadows bled across the room, stretching like claws across the tatami.

Izuku stayed motionless, but inside he unraveled.

“I have to admit, I was never planning on discussing those DNA results with a soul,” One continued. “I was going to just show you quiet favoritism. Maybe take you out to dinner a couple of times much like I’d done with Tomura. I figured we could slowly build up a more personal relationship.”

Izuku’s stomach turned. Shame burned through him like acid.

“But then you slaughtered over twenty Vipers,” One angrily reminded him. “I then needed to ask Tomura why the hell you were on a date with Chisaki Kai in the first place. And after that, he had no choice but to confess his little scheme to try to merge the Vipers with the Yakuza.”

Izuku lowered his head, throat dry.

His eyes locked on the rippling surface of his tea. His reflection trembled.

“He told me everything,” One hissed, voice sharp. “He confessed how he’s been priming you for Kai. How he orchestrated the perfect debut and how he sold your virginity to Kai for a goddamn seat at The Underground Council table. I will admit, it was a good bargain. But given the financial stress you have put on The Viper Academy—I told him you’re worth far more.”

He stood and circled the table slowly, each step a threat.

And then—his hand landed on Izuku's shoulder.

It was heavy. Not just with weight, but with possession, power and control. No warmth. No softness. Only a reminder: you are mine because you are my blood. There was nothing fatherly in his touch.

Izuku thought of Aizawa then.

He recalled his quiet, steady patience. The grace in his voice. The way he checked on them without needing to say a word.

The contrast between One and Aizawa made Izuku miss him.

"The Chisakis are big on family," One continued. "They have been lifelong friends of mine, and once upon a time, I thought I could be one of them. But the differences between us were too great to overcome. They are a line of pure bred prodigies. Bringing an orphan into the family who didn't know his parents was beneath them. I possessed no legacy, only a sword and poison to my name."

He paused and then sucked at his teeth.

"However," he continued. "I gained their trust over decades. I built an empire from the ground up that matched their lavish lifestyle. And when I succeeded in doing that over forty years ago, Takeshi was impressed."

One hummed lightly and tilted his head.

"He said that if I ever had a son or daughter, he would consider a marriage bond between us. But it would have to be a biological child, per their traditional morals. And the child had to meet their standards of beauty—which is why Inko was *perfect* to be the mother of my children. I knew her looks would pass down easily to our children."

Izuku began to feel sick.

"But when she escaped," One sighed then, angry. "I gave up. I pushed the whole idea to the side for decades and never pursued it again. But it seems like Tomura and I are more alike than you and I. He came up with the same goal as I did, all those years ago. And what luck it is that Inko was actually able to give me a child. A gorgeous one at that."

One turned to Izuku then. "Do you get the picture here?"

The hand on his shoulder tightened, and the words were squeezed out of him.

"I do," Izuku whispered, voice tight.

"I know you're trained in seduction tactics," One said, more threat than statement. "If you're wise, you will use them and behave from now on. We will merge with the Shie Hassaikai and fix your mess. If you successfully convince that spoiled brat to marry you, I'll consider all this forgiven."

One then began to turn to leave. He stopped briefly and finished his tea. When he placed down the cup, he paused. He hummed thoughtfully and turned to Izuku.

“I suppose you should know this,” One sneered. “My name is Shigaraki Zen.”

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku remained in the sunroom long after Zen left, rooted in place. The hours slipped by unnoticed, swallowed by silence and the slow, drowsy light drifting through the paper-paneled walls. Snow drifted lazily outside the window, and still he did not move.

Eventually, he looked down at his hands.

They trembled faintly in his lap. But what struck him most was how familiar they looked. The curve of his fingers. The shape of his knuckles. They weren’t his father’s, they were hers. Inko’s.

And for the first time in his life, Izuku truly saw her.

He saw a beautiful young woman, barely more than a girl, trapped beneath the crushing weight of her circumstances. He saw the fear she likely wore, and felt the pain she endured. He never considered what type of situation she must’ve been in to be caged by someone like Zen for her looks.

But if he’d been anything like Chisaki, entitled and possessive, he hurt for her.

He pictured her carrying a child born from that fear, and then making the impossible choice to leave it behind in order to survive.

And suddenly, all the bitterness he’d carried with him for years began to dissolve. Piece by piece, it slid off his skin, shedding like a layer of his old self. The resentment he’d buried deep, that ache of being unwanted, disappeared into the breeze.

If she saw Zen in him—then Izuku didn’t blame her. How could he? If he was able to get pregnant, he was unsure if he could love the child of a man like Zen or Chisaki.

That thought hit him like a hammer.

If she looked at him and saw her worst nightmare staring back, then maybe she hadn’t abandoned him.

Maybe she’d been trying to save them both.

She didn’t have intentions of him landing back here with Zen. Because if she did, she wouldn’t have run away from the man. Life was just cruel to him, and placed him ironically back into the hands of his violent father.

Izuku rose at last from the floor. His movements were slow like a soul returning to a body that no longer felt like home. Outside, the sky shifted colors. It was now washed in pale

orange and bruised with purple dusk.

He stepped out of the room.

Uraraka was waiting in the hall, standing quietly like she'd been there for hours. Their eyes met, and only then did Izuku feel the tears on his face. They were cold and stiff with dried salt.

Without a word, she walked to him and gently wiped his cheeks clean with the sleeve of her kimono. Her touch was light, methodical, and when she was done, she smoothed his hair back into place with quiet care. She did this not like a servant, and not even like a friend. Just someone who had nothing else left to give to Izuku but dignity.

When she finished, she stepped back and folded her hands in front of her.

Izuku wanted to thank her. The words hovered on his tongue but never formed. They felt too heavy, like trying to speak with a stone lodged in his throat.

So he just walked.

His bare feet whispered against the wooden floors that gleamed like polished bone. Behind him, Uraraka followed at a respectful distance, saying nothing. She didn't try to guide him or offer comfort—perhaps because she knew there was no place safe enough to go.

The whole time, his gaze never lifted. He didn't see the priceless paintings or the intricate gold filigree carved into the moldings of the walls. The world shrunk to the weight in his chest and the noise in his mind.

Zen being his father echoed. It mixed alongside a thousand other truths that didn't belong to the life he thought he had.

His fingers twitched at his sides. He didn't know if he wanted to scream or fall apart.

And then—he passed by a door near the first floor. It was faintly ajar and he could see silhouettes against the paper sheets. A sliver of voices leaked through the frame. Familiar ones.

"We just came back from Biei," informed one Viper, casually detached.

"And?" Tomura's voice, sharp and expectant.

"He's confirmed dead. The grave was undisturbed, just how we left it. We opened the casket. It looks like he drowned, face down in his own blood. The smell was foul so we didn't pull him out fully, it seems like he's already decomposing. We nailed his body back up after we saw that."

Izuku stopped breathing.

He tried—he tried *so* hard—but the air never made it to his lungs. A stuttering, high-pitched gasp cracked from his throat and caught there like glass. His eyes went wide and the world

bent in half, spiraling in on itself. The hallway tilted. The walls rippled. The sound of his heartbeat thundered, relentless.

Katsuki was dead.

No—no, no, no.

He dropped.

His knees hit the floor hard, and the pain barely registered. Everything inside him ignited and collapsed all at once. A tidal wave of fire and grief so deep swallowed him whole.

His hands clutched at his face as a sob tore out of him. Raw. Gut-deep. Shattering.

Then suddenly, the doors flung open.

Tomura stood in the frame, staring at him with a flicker of shock, as if he hadn't meant for him to hear that.

Their eyes locked.

Izuku's sob broke into a scream that finally made it past his throat. He scrambled backward, heels dragging against the floor, trying to push himself away even as Tomura moved toward him. His hands trembled, and his heart—

His heart broke.

It shattered in a way he never thought was possible.

"You killed him," Izuku cried, voice hollow and frayed. His face crumpled as fresh tears poured down. "Y-You really…you really killed him."

Tomura's expression cracked.

He took a slow step forward, squatted down, and reached out a hand.

But the moment his fingers brushed Izuku's skin, everything in Izuku burned like he'd been branded. Izuku flinched violently, ripped his arm away, and shoved Tomura with every ounce of strength he had left.

"Don't touch me!" he screamed, voice splitting at the seams.

The yell bounced off the walls and barreled into the stillness. Everyone in the vicinity stopped moving. Servants stared. Vipers and Yakuza guards alike turned to him. And Tomura, he didn't move. He stood there, stunned, his hand still half-raised as if reaching for something that was no longer there. He stood up slowly, taken back.

Izuku's body trembled as he stood, eyes locked onto his brother's.

He stumbled back, clutching at his chest—because it *hurt*. It hurt so badly he thought he might rip himself apart just to make it stop. He pressed his palm over where his heart used to be. The hollow space was quickly turning into a black void of sadness threatening to swallow him whole.

His tears refused to stop, spilling over as he thought of Katsuki's final moments.

He must've been so terrified and alone. The idea was unbearable and it demolished the last part of Izuku that'd been clinging to life. But what made it worse was that Katsuki loved Izuku enough to try to save him—and died for it.

The love of his life had been killed by his cruel, older brother.

Izuku's vision blurred. He looked down at his empty left hand—where the ring should have been. Where it *belonged*. He pressed it to his chest and turned.

And then he ran.

He ran blindly, anywhere, as far away from Tomura as his shaking legs would carry him. He ran from the hallway, from grief, from the ghost of a love now buried in a grave.

And behind him, Tomura did not follow.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku was always told all his life that he was immune to poison.

He consumed it until his tongue bled, until the ulcers in his stomach healed, and until he could no longer feel the bite of its bitterness. He thought there was no venom on this planet that would be able to hurt him—but no one warned him of love.

Love destroyed him from the inside out, and it claimed the one light in his life.

He tried to run away from this fact. He tried so hard but his grief stayed on his heels, tracking him down and showing him all his mistakes.

He ran until he couldn't anymore, trapped in a dead end of the Chisaki estate.

The light outside was gone now. It was only darkness and the sick yellow tint of the hallway lanterns that were spaced few and far between. Izuku wandered to the darkest part of the estate and the walls felt like they were closing in on him.

He cried, sobbing loudly like a banshee haunting the halls. Everywhere he looked he felt suffocated. All the golden statues glared at him at every turn. Their gemmed eyes pierced into him like they knew he was the one responsible for Katsuki's death.

If it weren't for him—Katsuki would still be *alive*, happy at the estate.

He would be there grumpily scowling and learning to live in his retirement. But instead, he got involved in Izuku's life. And now, he was buried in the grave site instead of tending to the

garden it surrounded.

Izuku stumbled in his running, feet tripping. He sobbed out loudly, and collapsed against the wall. He clutched above his heart. He clutched as he tried to keep walking. He began to slow down, crying every step of the way. He walked until he felt all the sadness inside of him double up unbearably.

Behind him, Uraraka finally caught up. Her face was stricken with pain but still, she didn't speak.

Izuku wandered until he reached a small shrine tucked into the furthest part of the estate.

The altar stood tall, bathed in warm gold and soft candlelight. It was adorned with delicate engravings and crowded with flowers, incense, and statues that glimmered under the flicker of the flames. Five portraits lined the top shelf—all Chisakis. All watching.

His legs buckled beneath him.

He collapsed in front of the altar, body folding in on itself like a paper figure soaked through. He sat there, grieving until his chest hallowed out. Time folded into nothing. Hours felt like minutes and seconds compressed into cruel, repeated memories of Katsuki.

When he was at the depths of his pain, he heard Tomura's footsteps approach.

His brother's usual powerful, dominant stride was subdued. He stopped directly beside Izuku, but didn't make eye contact. Quietly, Tomura took a seat beside Izuku on his hunches.

He gazed up to the altar, contemplative.

"I…didn't have any intentions for it to be this painful," Tomura offered.

He then reached in his pocket and hesitantly pulled something out. Izuku turned his head to see, and there he found a small, plastic bag, tied neatly at the top.

Izuku's crying trailed off to a steady sniffle. His brows pulled together as Tomura placed the bag in front of him. His hand lingered as he did so, hovering as if he was unsure if he was making the right decision. He frowned deeply. And in his eyes was a mix of coldness plus the ounce of mercy he somehow always saved for Izuku.

"Don't let Chisaki see these," Tomura whispered.

And that was it.

He stood up, and wordlessly turned around. No other words were exchanged as he exited back down the long, dark hallway. Izuku watched him go, confused.

When his brother was completely out of sight and his footsteps were gone, Izuku turned to the bag. He untied it, and glanced inside. His breath hitched and an unsteady, broken sob slipped.

Waiting inside were the two disposable cameras he and Katsuki bought—and his ring.

With trembling fingers, he reached in. He cradled the ring, and its rubies caught the candle light. It twinkled, and another hoarse sob spilled from his lips. He curled the ring in his hand and held it closer to him, trying to cherish the last piece of Katsuki he had.

His head lifted slowly and looked up at the altar.

And then he saw them.

In the flicker of the candlelight, kneeling before the shrine, was everyone he'd ever killed. They appeared in neat, silent rows, cloaked in memory and blood.

Nameless faces of people he murdered on assignments shadowed the back. So many figures he didn't know, and couldn't even name. He could barely recall some of their faces as they stacked on top of each other. And sitting in front of those lost souls, he saw his siblings. Aoyama, Ibara, Hiryu, Himiko and Jin gazed at him. Their stares were a mix of cold and affection. But they all stared at him full of pity.

Then finally, kneeling in front closest to him, were Katsuki and Mitsuki.

They were side by side, staring at him with warm, lovely red eyes.

It clicked then.

He understood his dead ex-husband far better now. He'd always grasped Katsuki's need for vengeance. He sympathized deeply with Katsuki's grief, but he never truly ever knew how it felt. He never knew what it was like to wear that kind of loss so close to his skin.

Not until now.

His shaking hands hugged his arms. He sobbed, progressively getting louder as depression finally caught him.

He struggled to understand that this was his new reality. How ironic, how one death changed everything when he spent his life surrounded by death. He delivered it. Witnessed it. He kept count of the bodies he claimed until the numbers blurred into nothing. He'd even murdered his own brothers and sisters.

But this was different. This was the kind of grief that felt wrong. Not simply sad or painful. But *wrong*.

It was as if his world tilted off its axis and refused to rebalance. And what caused it to tilt was the indignation. The injustice of a wrongful murder didn't sit beneath his sorrow; it sat on top of it. It was a crushing weight that made it impossible to breathe, let alone move forward.

Now he understood that rusted, dragging shackle Katsuki had carried behind his every step.

Izuku was floating in his mourning now, unmoored. No anchor. No compass.

Katsuki was gone.

He clawed at his chest like he could tear out his grief. His fingers trembled as they dragged across skin. But it wouldn't move. Wouldn't lift. It was wedged beneath the weight of injustice, a boulder that refused to budge.

His palms began to itch. A thought in the back of his head grew louder as the itching grew more and more intense. It whispered to him: the only way to ease it was to balance the scales. A life for a life. A truth older than law.

Only then—*maybe*—could his grief fly free.

The glow of the candle lit his figure in the dark and he turned and showed his face to the world. His eyes were bloodshot, red, and his cheeks were streaked with tears. Anger was marred so deep into his face that his viridian eyes glowed with wrath.

He stood up, shoulders heavy and anger on full boil. He curled his fist around the ring as he walked up to the window. Down below, he could see Tomura and Zen. They were walking away from the Chisaki estate towards their cars, talking.

Izuku stopped crying then. His sadness transformed to hatred, then to unparalleled rage. His eyes darkened to the point of no return as a scornful glare took over his face.

If it was a wedding they wanted—then *fine*. A wedding they would get.

And Izuku would make sure it'll be a wedding everyone in Japan would remember for decades.

Chapter End Notes

Let me know what you guys think below!! ❤️ I'm eager to hear everyone's thoughts, screams, theories and more 🥳

Everything is finally coming to a peak and merging together :') According to my outline, there's ~7 chapters left, which is insane. But who knows tbh so many times in this story chapters I outlined to be one chapter split into four chapters lol (all the flashback/rewind chapters did that) so I am very stoked to get into this last bit!!

Thanks so much for reading <3

Chapter 44: Accelerando

Chapter Summary

Accelerando (Tempo indicator) — A gradual increase in tempo.

Chapter Notes

Hellooo!! I'm back from my break! :'D IM SO HAPPY TO BE BACK WITH THESE ANGSTY BOYS!!!
If you're still around I'm so thankful and happy you guys are here. Really :)) you are all so amazing. Commenters and silent readers alike, I appreciate you! <3

First, thank you to the LOML, Luna, for Betaing like always!! Now lets get started :D

I hope you guys enjoyed the last 60 days of peace, we're done with that now <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 44 — Accelerando

.

.

.

Izuku stalked through the dark hallways, not uttering a word.

The weight of the small plastic bag in his hand was heavier than it should've been.

Originally, Izuku thought their disposable cameras were gone, along with all the memories. During the ambush, the small items were left behind in the chaos. But, now that he reflected on it, it made sense his brother swept Aizawa's cabin for any proof of Izuku's rebellion. Tomura was probably going to burn every lick of evidence to hide what he considered to be Izuku's 'defect'.

But now, his and Katsuki's memories were given back to him—as a *gift*.

Handed over by the same man who killed the love of his life.

Izuku's fingers clenched tighter around the bag until his nails bit into his palms. The anger inside him burned hotter than anything he'd ever felt before.

When he reached the door of his new imprisonment, he paused and turned.

Ochako was standing there, small and unmoving. In the dim hallway light, her figure was half-silhouetted. She didn't make a move towards him. She simply waited, still and steady, like she'd been this entire time.

Izuku scrubbed at his eyes with the back of his hand and cleared his throat.

"Um…thank you," he rasped, voice rough from crying. "For everything. And sorry for being so quiet. I know it's probably uncomfortable for you."

"You don't have to apologize," she gently replied. "If you don't feel like talking, that's okay."

Something about the way she said that made him stop. He looked at her again, properly this time. Fatigue sat heavy on her shoulders, and there was a slight slump in her posture. His eyes cut down and noted the faint tremble in her hands she tried to hide.

"…Is your name really Uraraka?" He asked, voice softer now. "Or is that just something the Chisakis call you?"

"My full name is Uraraka Ochako," she replied. "They use my family name."

"Do you prefer Uraraka or Ochako?"

She blinked, startled. "I—I prefer whatever you prefer."

Izuku gave a tired, weak head shake. "And if I said I prefer whatever *you* prefer?"

"Then…I like to be called Ochako," she admitted quietly.

A flicker of warmth broke through his exhaustion. He stepped closer and peered down at the plastic bag.

Carefully, he removed the ring tucked inside and held the bag out to her.

"If it's not too much trouble," he said, barely above a whisper, "Would you mind getting these photos developed for me?"

Ochako's face lit up. "Of course," she replied immediately, accepting the bag. "I'll have them ready for you by breakfast."

Izuku gave her the faintest smile he could manage. "Thank you, Ochako."

"Of course, sir—"

"—You don't have to call me sir," he interrupted. "You can call me Izuku."

She hesitated. "…Are you sure?"

“I’m sure.”

“Okay. Then thank you, Izuku.” Her smile returned, a little tentative but earnest. “I’ll see you in the morning. Please, try to rest.”

“Thank you, same to you.”

They said their goodbyes quietly. As she walked away, Izuku lingered in the silence for a moment longer. When he was alone, the pain returned. The rawness of it permeated him entirely and moved his body for him. With a heavy heart, he opened his new bedroom door and stepped inside.

His bloodshot eyes raked across the glittering items. As he did this, gradually, his rage started to hold hands with his sadness. He changed into the pajamas that were laid out on his new bed.

Right as he changed clothes, he heard faint footsteps outside his door.

He quieted a bit and noted it was two people. Guards, more than likely.

When he got into bed, the grief and resentment in his heart doubled. Then it tripled. Then it became so vast, Izuku couldn’t see past it anymore. He laid on his back, like a man adrift in a dark ocean. No anchor and no shore in sight. In front of him was only fog, and the memory of someone who’d once been all the color in his life.

Izuku’s eyes burned, and he curled his fingers tightly around the wedding ring. His thumb rubbed slow, desperate circles against the rubies, as if he could conjure his dead husband’s heartbeat back into him.

His anger spoke to him and it viciously asked him what *Katsuki* would want to be done.

But Izuku didn’t have to think for long.

He knew Katsuki would want him to make that wedding a living hell.

ɯɯɯ

He didn’t sleep all night. Instead, a quiet, burning blend of pain and vengeance consumed him.

He shrouded himself with it, wearing the loss of Katsuki like a new layer of skin. It hardened his exterior as he prepared for the day. He dressed in one of the all black custom made samues that held the symbol of the two winding viper on the back.

He walked over to the dresser. This time, he sifted through all the expensive jewelry that was placed in his room. He quietly raked his eyes over all the metals and jewels. Most of them were green, the same color of his eyes. A pitiful attempt by Chisaki Kai to make him feel *special*, no doubt.

Izuku soured.

He passed up all the emeralds and picked up a small, delicate silver chain. He threaded his wedding ring on it and clasped it around his neck. For a long time, he stared into the mirror. The rubies caught the light, and behind him Izuku could feel the phantom presence of Katsuki press against him, hugging his shoulders.

Izuku somberly kissed the ring, and tucked it away under his collar.

He turned on his heels to the door. The first thing he noted was that Ochako was missing this morning. In her place, he was escorted down to the dining hall by two guards. Izuku sat alone for a while at the large table. And when his breakfast arrived, he couldn't conjure an appetite, yet again.

Half way through pushing around his eggs, Ochako arrived with a small paper bag in her hands. He perked up, and his heart skipped a beat. She approached him with a thoughtful expression and quietly laid down the two thick sets of photos beside his plate.

"Good morning," she greeted. "As you've requested."

"Thank you," Izuku replied quietly.

Ochako lingered for a moment, gazing at him sadly.

"Um," she mumbled. She looked down and to the side. "You two were a beautiful couple."

Izuku's eyes widened, and his head snapped towards her.

She then quickly bowed and assumed her position in the corner, fading into the background. For a moment, Izuku was stunned, blinking back tears. A sudden, sharp pain in his chest sparked and his anger flattered.

His fingers trembled as he tried to muster up the strength to look at the photos.

And when he did, his heart broke all over again.

There was more than he thought. There were photos of them in the car. On the train. In the grass and in front of frivolous tourist attractions. There was even one of them on top of the hood of the car, smiling together. He recalled the sun baked asphalt ribboning through the landscape and the blur of roadside scenery. Their entire journey had been captured in countless photos, each click a tiny burst of sound against the hum of tires.

He paused on one photo of him standing solemnly in front of the train station. He could still hear Katsuki's smug, teasing voice behind the camera.

"Look this way, darling," Katsuki had said that evening. "One day we'll look back on these photos fondly."

"Yeah," Izuku whispered distantly. He echoed the same sentence he'd said back to Katsuki. "One day."

He thumbed through picture after picture, reliving their trip to the cabin. He hunched over and his eyes began to sting again. As he looked at these photographs, he finally thought deeper about the night of Katsuki's death.

First, the divorce papers came to mind. In Izuku's opinion, that one stung the most.

Tomura robbed them of something that meant so much to both of them. He couldn't even let Izuku be a widow in the end. Because really, why did his brother go through the trouble to file the divorce if he was going to kill Katsuki anyways?

Spite was the only answer.

He destoryed their marriage because he could, nothing more.

Next, the deal between Tomura and Katsuki finally demanded attention. He had been avoiding it. He didn't want to think there was ever a moment Katsuki and Tomura agreed on anything—but it made sense. In a way, Tomura attempted to rob them of trust too.

But deep down, Izuku didn't blame Katsuki.

He knew Tomura and Katsuki all too well. Without any doubt in his mind, he knew his brother must've manipulated Katsuki. He didn't exactly know the logistics, but he knew it couldn't have been a fair fight.

His brother zeroed in on people's weaknesses and used them to his advantage. If what Tomura said about giving Katsuki the license plate number was true, then he must've offered the deal directly after the masquerade. And that was Katsuki's lowest moment in Izuku's eyes. Katsuki just discovered his lover killed his *mother* in one of the worst ways.

If Katsuki encountered Tomura when he was at his most vulnerable—he never stood a chance.

Izuku knew this, because he'd lived it. He'd been there, over and over, caught in Tomura's chess games. So many times he thought he had a choice when really, he never did. And that was Tomura's real talent. He didn't only break people with fists or bullets. He broke people by making them think they'd chosen their cage.

But Izuku saw through it now.

For the first time in his life, he understood Tomura clearly. And he promised himself he would never fall for his brother's manipulation ever again.

He flipped slowly through each photo, and his heart skipped when he got to a particular one. It was a photo that neither of them took. Someone in the cabin must've done it.

The photo was taken in the cozy yellow light of the fireplace. They were on the couch, wrapped up in a small blanket with Izuku resting peacefully pressed against Katsuki. His dead lover's arm was hooked around his waist, and they were blissfully unaware of their surroundings. They were both smiling, talking about something.

But what was more eye-catching was the amount of love pouring out of both of their eyes.

A teardrop hit the photo.

Suddenly, the sound of Tomura's footsteps began to draw near.

Izuku straightened at once, and his spine went rigid.

He wiped the tears from his cheeks with the back of his sleeve and quickly gathered the photographs into their folder. He tucked them out of sight beneath the table. His chest ached at the thought of Tomura laying eyes on them. The idea of Katsuki's smile being scrutinized by his murderer felt unbearable.

The doors slid open with a soft hiss.

Tomura entered, composed and cold. He dressed in casual black clothes that deepened the pallor of his skin. His silver piercings glinted sharply in the morning light. His eyes swept across the room, pausing on each Yakuza soldier with a curt, almost royal nod before finally drifting to Izuku.

Izuku slipped on his emotional mask and clutched the photos in his lap.

"Good morning," Tomura greeted, his voice low and smooth.

"Morning," Izuku replied quietly.

Tomura crossed the room and walked up to him. He didn't look him in the eye as he sat down a small stress-ball next to his utensil. Izuku gazed at it unhappily. It was red, damn near the same color as Katsuki's eyes.

Bitterly, Izuku wondered if that was on purpose.

His brother then took his seat across the dining table. Silence stretched between them, thick and loaded, until Tomura finally looked away and folded his hands in front of him. A servant appeared with his breakfast, all its contents arranged neatly.

Without hesitation, Tomura began to eat.

He was poised when he did it, never chewing too loud and not eating too fast. He savored each bite elegantly, and precisely cut every piece of meat.

As he took his time, that's when Izuku realized why Tomura always held the upper hand. He had patience. Endless, eerie patience that could outlast even the Grim Reaper. He'd plotted for years to kill Nine. And now, he manipulated Chisaki so expertly in the last half a decade that the man hadn't even noticed the strings being pulled beneath his feet.

Izuku swallowed his anger and molded it into a weapon that would last. He could no longer be the desperate, naïve boy who clung to fantasies and fairytales. He decided to follow his brother's lead.

If he was going to get revenge for Katsuki, he needed to play the long game too.

“Ochako,” Izuku called gently.

She looked up from her corner by the door, her eyes alert and kind.

Izuku gave her a soft smile. “If it’s not too much trouble, would you mind excusing the guards? I’d like a moment alone with my brother.”

“Oh! Of course.” She gave a polite bow, then turned to the men stationed near the walls. “We’ll be right outside. Take your time.”

She was nice, Izuku noted. Too nice for a place like this, and it made him sad to wonder why she would be indebted to people like the Chisakis.

Izuku waited until the last of them stepped out, the door clicking shut behind them. Once everyone was gone and it was only them, the two brothers caught each other’s gaze.

“Did you want to talk about Bakugou?” Tomura asked, a bit too casual for Izuku’s liking.

Izuku took a moment to compose himself. He watched his brother closely, shifting gears. He carefully curated himself to appear both compliant and broken enough to be believable.

“We should be on the same page about the story you told Chisaki,” Izuku replied, voice steady but soft.

Tomura looked up from his coffee, brow raised. “What do you mean?”

“If we want him to marry me, I need to know what version of me he’s buying into.”

Tomura set his cup down, studying him. “You’re going to go along with the plan this easily?”

“Yes,” Izuku replied. “I—I’ve learned my place.”

Tomura narrowed his eyes, clearly not fully convinced.

“If I’m going to sell the part,” Izuku added, lacing his voice with meekness, “I need to know what story I’m walking into. I want to make sure we’re aligned.”

Tomura’s gaze lingered, then he nodded slowly. He leaned back and folded his hands neatly.

“All right,” he said. “You’re right. You should know. I gave the Chisakis a version of the truth that made you look like the victim.”

Izuku nodded once. “What’d you say?”

“I told them Bakugou found out you killed his mother on Yakuza orders,” Tomura said matter-of-factly. “Then I said he found out Chisaki Kai was interested in you, and used that to hurt both of you in retaliation.”

Izuku blinked. “And Chisaki Kai believed that?”

“Yes,” Tomura replied. “He’s so self-absorbed it wasn’t hard to feed into his ego. I said Bakugou ambushed you on your mission to kill Peter Moore, got you drunk, and tricked you into marrying him. And you, being a loyal Viper, tried to get a divorce.”

“…But he refused to sign the papers,” Izuku added, guessing Tomura’s angle.

“Exactly,” Tomura confirmed. “It was good that you told me where the divorce documents were before you defected. I showed them to Chisaki. The date next to your signature was before the masquerade. That detail was enough to clear you of being Bakugou’s accomplice in the murder of the five Chisakis.”

Izuku’s fingers tightened around the stack of photographs in his lap. His knuckles whitened as he forced himself to remain composed.

“And Katsuki’s motive for killing them,” Izuku said slowly, “you told him it was revenge for his mother?”

Tomura nodded. “That, and to frame you. I said Bakugou isolated you and made sure you had no one to turn to. Then, once you were scared and alone, he moved in and took advantage of your vulnerability. Claimed you for himself. Not out of love—but just to spite Chisaki.”

Izuku clenched his jaw and fury flared beneath his skin.

“And what was the reason I stayed with him?” Izuku asked tightly.

“Because you’re naïve,” Tomura answered easily. “You fell for Bakugou’s scheme because you’re sheltered and hold on to silly notions of love and romance. He manipulated you.”

Izuku clutched the photos harder.

It was a carefully spun web of lies, but held a couple of holes. But like Tomura said, Chisaki was vain. And egotistical men didn’t look for faults in stories that made them feel important.

He swallowed the bile rising in his throat and nodded once more, stiffly.

Tomura caught his discomfort and frowned. “Are you feeling alright?”

“I am,” Izuku replied. “Thank you for catching me up to speed.”

A silence stretched between them, taut and heavy. Tomura eventually returned to his meal, methodical in every bite. When he finished, his eyes flicked to Izuku’s plate that was still full. His lips thinned, but he didn’t press the matter. Instead, he exhaled sharply through his nose, displeased.

“How did the conversation with One go?” he asked.

Izuku blinked. He shifted his fork, pushing a piece of egg across the porcelain plate.

“As well as it could’ve,” he said truthfully.

Tomura clicked his tongue. “So he told you.”

“That I’m his son? Yeah. He did.”

“And how does that make you feel?”

Disgusting. Filthy.

“…Content,” Izuku lied, keeping his face carefully blank. “Now that I know, it feels like things make more sense. Like I know what I’m supposed to do.”

Tomura studied him for a beat longer than was comfortable, then nodded.

“That’s good, Izuku,” he said, with a trace of cautious approval. “I’m glad you’re finally seeing the bigger picture. If there’s anything else you want to ask, now’s the time.”

There was one thing flickering around in the back of his mind.

“The others from the cabin,” Izuku murmured, eyes still fixed on his untouched food. “What happened to them? Did you…?”

“No,” Tomura answered, his voice clipped. “They got away.”

Izuku’s heart skipped. He looked up.

“But we’re in the process of tracking them now,” Tomura continued. “It’s only a matter of time.”

Izuku froze. “You’re going to kill them too?”

“Stupid questions aren’t like you,” Tomura chastised. His tone hardened, and his eyes narrowed. “You know as well as I do we don’t tolerate loose ends.”

“O-Of course,” Izuku replied shakily. He swallowed thickly and nodded slowly. “No loose ends.”

They didn’t speak again for a while. In the silence, Izuku hoped with everything in his heart that Aizawa and the rest of Katsuki’s friends got far away and never looked back. But he realized the worst: they didn’t know Katsuki was dead. They didn’t know where his body was, and Izuku felt so much shame and guilt for being the reason he up-ended all their lives.

Shinsou’s harsh words echoed in his head: *“He might be the death of him. Izuku is not normal.”*

In the end, Shinsou was right. Izuku was the death of Katsuki.

Self-loathing wrapped around his throat, making him wish he wasn’t breathing.

As their quiet meal came to an end, Tomura stood and slid his coat over his shoulders. He didn’t look at Izuku, his attention already drifting toward his phone. His thumbs tapped out a

message with swift precision.

“I’ll be in and out the next few days,” Tomura informed casually, eyes still fixed on the screen. “One wants to meet with us the day before the Chisakis’ return. Just to make sure we’re aligned, this deal has to go through clean.”

“Understood,” Izuku murmured, folding his hands over the photos in his lap.

Tomura paused, then reached into his coat and pulled out a small glass vial. He set it down on the table between them with a soft clink. The liquid inside was a deep, unnatural blue. Thick, almost syrupy, with tiny air bubbles suspended in it.

“Here’s your master-mix for toxins and poisons.” Tomura looked at him and slid his phone into his pocket along with both his hands. “Your tolerance has dropped too low. You know what to do: one drop to start off with, then work your way up to three a day after a couple of weeks. When you’re running low, let me know.”

“Ah, right,” Izuku muttered distantly. “Thank you, Big Brother.”

The words tasted bitter coming out, but they landed sweetly in Tomura’s ears. His eyes sparked with subtle approval, and a small satisfied nod followed.

“You’re welcome,” Tomura replied. “Get some more rest, Izuku.”

And with that, he turned and left, his footsteps echoing as the door clicked shut behind him.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When Izuku got back to his room, his mask slipped.

All the emotions he forced down came back, full force. His hands shook, his body trembled, and his heart ached. He placed the pictures down on his dresser and went to the bathroom. He untucked the ring around his neck and shut the door tightly behind him.

With a bitter gaze, he eyed the vial in his grasp.

It was almost ironic how their lives worked, Izuku thought to himself. How easily they accepted poisoning themselves—both literally and figuratively. This vial wasn’t the only poison they swallowed. They consumed it in their teachings, in their training, and in every command barked at them. All they ever did was poison themselves.

And Izuku was done with it.

Without ceremony, he turned the faucet on. The smooth water ran in a steady stream.

He angrily pulled off the cork top and tipped the vial. His fingers didn’t shake, and his eyes didn’t blink. Thicker than water, the bright liquid swirled down the golden drain. Sharp, metallic scent rushed up, curling into his nose. The smell awoke terrible, putrid memories. He saw all the beatings, the trainings, and all the deaths he witnessed wash down with the liquid.

And Izuku watched every drop vanish.

He held the empty vial a moment longer, then set it gently on the counter beside the sink. In the mirror, he caught his spiteful reflection looking back at him.

He had no intention of becoming a Viper, ever again.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When Izuku stepped out of his room, Ochako was waiting for him. She was quiet, composed, and small against the gilded hallway. She offered him a smile that didn't quite reach her eyes.

He took a few steps forward, and without needing to be told, she began to follow a couple steps behind.

After a moment, he glanced over his shoulder.

"You don't have to linger behind me," he told her softly. "You can walk beside me."

Ochako blinked, startled. "Are you sure?"

"Yeah." He managed a polite smile. "I'd prefer it."

She hesitated for a breath. Then she took two light steps to fall into stride beside him. Once they were shoulder to shoulder, their eyes met briefly and a quiet understanding passed between them.

"So," Izuku asked, voice low, "what's your favorite thing to do here?"

"There's not much we're allowed to do outside of work," she answered with a small shrug. "The Chisakis keep us busy."

"Do you get breaks?"

"Sometimes. I took one last night after you went to bed."

"And what do you do when you get them?"

She smiled faintly. "I like to sit in the garden. It's very beautiful and serene."

"That does sound nice," Izuku murmured.

As they strolled down the jade and gold corridor, Izuku took in the opulence with distant eyes. The walls were lined with a strange clash of styles: traditional watercolor paintings in delicate wood frames sat beside massive, hyper-realistic oil works of the Chisaki lineage. One in particular made his lip curl. It was a portrait of Chisaki Kai standing regally beside a black bear, eyes full of arrogance and entitlement.

But what struck Izuku more were the people moving quietly in and out of view. Other servants shuffled by in dull grey clothes, walking in the shadows in hopes of shrinking into

them. They passed without eye contact, faces blank, and shoulders slumped.

Izuku surveyed them closely. Then he whispered, “Is it okay if I ask you something personal?”

Ochako turned to him with a polite, practiced smile. “Of course.”

“Why are you here?” he asked. “And how did you end up indebted to the Chisakis?”

She stiffened at first, then let out a hollow laugh. “That’s two questions.”

“Ah—sorry.” Izuku scratched the back of his neck, mildly embarrassed. “You don’t have to answer. I let my curiosity get ahead of me.”

“No, it’s okay,” she said softly. “If anyone deserves honesty, it’s you.”

She looked straight ahead as she spoke, voice hushed.

“It was my grandfather. He took out a loan from the Yakuza during the factory boom. He wanted to start his own business and ride the wave of wealth like everyone else. At first, it looked like it would work. But then the market crashed and he lost everything. He accumulated more debt than he ever borrowed with interest.”

Izuku’s brow furrowed, listening closely.

“The Chisakis offered a solution,” she continued. “He could work it off—basic wage with grueling hours. Or he could lose his head and family. Obviously, it wasn’t really a choice. But then he died, and the debt passed to my father. But my dad got hurt and couldn’t keep working. So I dropped out of school, signed my name on the contract, and took on the debt to keep them from killing us.”

Her voice cracked slightly at the end.

“They said they’d only wipe the slate clean if they killed us all,” she whispered. “Me, my parents and my little brother and sister. So…I offered myself up. This way, my siblings can continue their education without worrying.”

Izuku’s chest tightened and his fists clenched at his sides. The photos of Katsuki suddenly layered over the vacant eyes of the servant who passed then.

“…Are most of the servants here in debt?” Izuku asked, disgusted.

She nodded. “Nearly all of us have some sort of generational debt. No matter what, someone always pays.”

Izuku stopped walking. He looked at Ochako. He *really* looked at her. There he saw a girl who sacrificed her freedom for the people she loved.

“I-I’m so sorry,” he whispered, voice breaking.

She smiled softly, but it didn't touch her eyes. "It's okay. I've accepted it. I work hard so if I ever have children, they won't inherit this. I want to be the last one."

Izuku felt sick. The taste of helplessness mixed with the slow-burning fire of grief. He turned his head as another servant passed and saw Katsuki in him—but more so, he saw Mitsuki. He saw an alternative path that could have been theirs if Mitsuki didn't flee Tokyo. He briefly wondered if that's why she ran instead of repaying them.

And something clicked.

Katsuki's death wasn't only because of Chisaki Kai.

It was the legacy he came from. It was the rot in the roots of the Chisaki family tree that spread across the country. From Kai's father to his grandfather and beyond. Their cruelty was disease passed down like simple inheritance. And if Kai had a child, it would begin again.

There would be more Ochakos. More Katsukis. More Mitsukis. More *graves*.

He blinked, eyes soft again as he gazed at Ochako.

"Thank you," he said quietly. "I appreciate you telling me. That was very eye opening."

"Of course," she replied. "If you have more questions I'm happy to answer."

"I think I'm good for now," Izuku said gently. "Would you show me the garden? I'd really like to see it."

ᔓᔓᔓ

The days that followed blurred into one another, blanketed beneath a steady fall of snow. It grew heavier with each passing morning, collecting against the windowpanes like nature itself was trying to muffle the world into silence.

True to his word, Tomura came and went. He made a point of having breakfast with Izuku every day, sitting across the long table in either crisp black or stunning white. No in between. He offered casual updates on The Viper Academy and how the rebuilding efforts were progressing. His voice was even, almost bored. It was as if they were discussing the weather and the last few months were merely a blip.

Izuku responded with nods, brief replies, and the occasional faint smile. While he came up with a plan for avenging Katsuki, he couldn't afford to show anything. Not sorrow. Not rage. Not fear. He expertly pressed down his emotions, suffocating them beneath a performance of obedience.

But the moment Tomura was gone, his mask disintegrated, and the flood poured out.

When he was alone, Izuku would weep. Grief clawed at his throat, hot and unrelenting. He mourned Katsuki in one long wave that never let him catch his breath. And he deeply feared that Aizawa and the others were next.

During these days, he couldn't find the strength to get out of bed after breakfast. He rotted away under the covers, refusing to step foot into the hallway. He stayed there, drowning in his sorrow, reliving Tomura killing Katsuki again and again.

On these nights, he slept with the photos in the bed. He would flip through them until he memorized every single last image.

Katsuki in the car. Katsuki laughing by the train. Katsuki with his confident, crooked smile in front of a tourist stand. When he held the photos, he could almost feel Katsuki beside him again. It was as if he were holding his hand, telling him he was still beside him. He could feel the ghost of the tiny hearts Katsuki used to trace into his skin with his fingertip.

But more importantly, with every single day that passed, Izuku's rage simmered hotter and hotter.

And when the day finally came to meet with Zen, Izuku's resentment was tightly coiled in his gut, waiting to strike.

ᔓᔓᔓ

They met in the west wing, in the Chisaki estate's opulent library. The room was cavernous, lined with floor-to-ceiling shelves that housed thousands of books. It smelled of old parchment and varnish, a scent both comforting and stifling. The furniture was all carved dark wood, bulky and regal, like it was stolen from a king's manor.

They took a seat privately in one of the reader's rooms. There were no Yakuza here. Only Viper guards and them, allowing them privacy. Zen was awaiting him already with Tomura. The two of them were seated at a small round wooden table with paperwork and pens.

Both sets of blood-red eyes cut up at him the moment he entered.

Izuku bowed politely, suppressing the chill crawling up his spine. He took the empty seat across from them. His expression was blank, carefully offering nothing of the grief and vengeful thirst beneath his skin.

Zen didn't waste a moment.

"Is your head on right, boy?" he spat harshly.

Izuku felt a sting behind the words. His throat tightened, but he forced a shallow nod.

"Yes, sir," he murmured.

"Good," Zen snipped, not bothering to hide his contempt. "Glad to hear you've come to your senses. Maybe your idiocy really was all that Bakugou brat's doing."

He leaned back in his chair with a dismissive shrug. There was no warmth and no hint of a second chance in his aura. Zen was many things, but forgiving was never one.

Zen turned to Tomura then, and his expression flipped. His eyes sparkled with approval, and his mouth nearly quirked into a smile.

“Good job in wrangling him,” he praised.

Tomura bowed his head with humility. “Of course.”

Zen cracked his neck with a grunt and reached for the paperwork. “Let’s get to the point. I’ve run the numbers, and we’re going to have to speed this up. The merger can’t afford to crawl, we need to accelerate things quickly. Tomura, I know you said Kai and Izuku would need time to warm up to each other, but if we move at a snail’s pace, we’re going to be buried in debt before spring hits.”

“Understood,” Tomura replied. He began scribbling notes in that meticulous way of his.

Zen didn’t even look up.

“217,” he said, using the number like a leash. “When Chisaki Kai returns, you’re going to need to make yourself indispensable. Smile, flatter him, and be exactly what he wants. Make him want you—for the long haul.”

Izuku’s jaw clenched, but he didn’t let it show.

“Understood, sir.”

Tomura eyed him quietly. His gaze flicked up and down Izuku’s form while the tip of his pen rhythmically tapped against his notepad.

Then, with a slight tilt of his head, he said, “Maybe you could do one of those elegant dances Ibara and Jin taught you. That always seemed to have the desired effect of making someone enamored.”

Izuku clicked his tongue against his teeth, irritation twitching beneath his skin.

“I could do that,” Izuku said. His voice was cool, distant. “It’s been a while, but I can brush up.”

“Then be sure to do that,” Tomura replied, tone easy but expectant.

“Of course, Big Brother.”

Tomura’s eyes flickered a bit, once again approving the title address.

Zen, who’d been quiet, huffed. “And don’t forget to emphasize that you’re still a virgin. I don’t believe it. But at this point, I doubt Chisaki Kai cares about the truth. He’ll believe whatever fantasy you sell him if you spin it right.”

Izuku’s eyes dropped to the table. “Understood.”

The rest of the conversation drifted on, gliding from topic to topic with a calculated ease. They discussed strategy on how to best press the right buttons when it came to the Chisakis.

Zen and Tomura coached him on topics to emphasize, and advised him on which ones to avoid. Izuku nodded along, committing every detail to memory. He began drafting a plan to charm Chisaki Kai the moment he returned.

Then, the talk pivoted to logistics surrounding The Academy. That was where Izuku zoned out. He didn't understand the operational side of The Academy, nor did he care to. Spread sheets, supply lines, and assignment quotas meant nothing to him.

What did catch his attention, however, was the easy rhythm of conversation between Zen and Tomura.

They spoke with matching cadences. Their tones echoed off one another in a way that only true familial bonds could create. It was unsettling, and almost cruel, to witness.

He wondered if Zen felt disappointed that Tomura wasn't really his son.

He barely had time to follow that thought before it was eviscerated by the next words out of Tomura's mouth.

"What about the next cohort?" Tomura asked. "Are we going to try my plan again?"

Izuku's eyes slid to his brother, and the ghost memory of Katsuma's infant screams grew louder inside his skull. His breathing slowed, like his lungs were afraid of what they might inhale next.

"I think we need to tweak your approach," Zen replied, stroking his chin. "I know you originally proposed the hospital method, which I still think is viable. But I'm leaning toward our older methods. Let's keep the cohort small like you recommended—but this time, let's aim for fifty. It's a cleaner number."

Tomura almost smiled. "I was actually thinking the same."

"Oh?" Zen glanced over, intrigued.

Tomura's smirk widened as he reached into his folder and slid a paper across the table. "I've already contacted a new trafficker. He was a direct competitor of Peter Moore's White Dove ring. A while ago he sent us a gift basket for taking him out. Said he'd offer us a discount on the next shipment to celebrate."

Zen laughed, dry and heartless. "If I'd known that, I would've slit that white devil's throat a decade earlier."

Both men chuckled. The sound was hollow, mirthless and made Izuku's skin crawl.

"What if we split the cohort?" Tomura suggested. "Half from hospitals, half trafficked. That way we save a bit of money, but still get the numbers we want."

“That’s efficient,” Zen agreed. “Let’s do that.”

“Perfect,” Tomura said, and it was the happiest Izuku heard him in years.

Izuku looked at him then. *Really* looked.

He studied the neat bun pulled tight at the back of his brother’s head, and the clinical coldness in his crimson eyes. He assessed the careful way he folded his hands over the notepad. Ugliness crept up his spine slowly. He’d always known Tomura ran their branch of The Viper Academy, but this was the first time he understood the unwavering nature of his brother’s cruelty.

No matter what, Tomura wouldn’t be stopped.

Izuku getting five kids out wouldn’t save the next fifty.

There would always be more kids.

More *Vipers*.

“I’ve also been considering a revamp to our disciplinary structure,” Tomura said casually, shifting in his seat to face Zen. “I think Bigs should be allowed a bit more freedom to correct their Littles—within reason, of course. Izuku always responded well to firm punishment.”

Zen’s gaze cut toward Izuku. “Is that true?”

“Ye—” Izuku’s voice cracked before the word was fully formed.

A rush of memories surged through him.

Kicks to the stomach, iron belt buckles, and days spent locked in the dark with nothing but his own heartbeat for company. His body nearly buckled at the ghost sensation of leather kissing his skin. He cleared his throat, forcing his body to still, and caught Zen’s curious glance from across the table.

“Y-Yes,” he managed at last, dropping his eyes.

Zen nodded, then turned back to Tomura. “Go on.”

And Tomura did.

He explained the punishments clinically. He talked about how the thinner edge of the belt left cleaner welts and how a sharp angle increased pain without breaking skin. He spoke like a craftsman describing his tools, and not a brother recounting beating him. Izuku stared at the woodgrain of the table as Tomura’s voice buzzed past his ears.

“How long did you use that method?” Zen asked when Tomura finished.

“Until he was twenty,” Tomura replied flatly. “After that, I transitioned him to famine punishments.”

Zen frowned. His eyes flicked to Izuku with a mild sneer. “Why stop? Seems like he needed a good beating more than ever this last year.”

Tomura tilted his head, as if genuinely reflecting. “It wasn’t by choice, really.”

“Then what?” Zen pressed.

“The first time Chisaki Kai saw Izuku, he was intrigued. But then his interest soured when he saw the welts on Izuku. The ones on his arms were especially off-putting.”

Zen scoffed. “Of course. That brat recoils from anything remotely ugly.”

“Yeah,” Tomura muttered. “I stopped using physical punishment to avoid leaving marks. Switching to famine allowed Izuku’s value to remain intact. That way, he could get Kai’s interest again and it wouldn’t be compromised.”

“Understandable,” Zen murmured, eyeing Izuku again. His gaze dropped to the younger man’s bare forearms, noting the tanned, unblemished skin. “Aside from a few faint scars on his hands, he looks clean.”

“That was the goal,” Tomura replied, voice devoid of remorse.

“Always thinking several steps ahead,” Zen happily mused.

The conversation moved on, but Izuku didn’t. He recalled that night where Tomura said he would stop hitting him. And while it hadn’t been the happiest memory—it was still a highlight for him in the bleakness of his life. But learning this, made it lose all its luster.

Zen excused himself to the bathroom. He strode away with his cane and one guard followed him.

Once Zen was out of earshot, Izuku turned to Tomura.

He kept his voice careful, “I thought you said you stopped hitting me with the belt because you realized it was too harsh.”

Tomura didn’t look at him right away. He let the question hang in the air for a beat before glancing sideways.

“That was the truth,” he replied smoothly. “It was too harsh, physically. Most of your value lies in your appearance. Punishments that leave scars devalue you. I need to correct you in ways that preserve your appeal.”

“So when you put me on that skincare regimen…”

He trailed off, unsure if he could stomach the answer.

But Tomura obliged anyway. “It was to make you more desirable to Chisaki, yes.”

Izuku’s heart dropped. His breath caught in his chest as the truth snapped into place.

"…You've been grooming me for him," he whispered, stunned. "This whole time."

Tomura met his gaze without shame.

"I have," he confirmed. "Is that a problem?"

His brother stared him down, daring him to step out of line.

"No," Izuku whispered. He twisted his hands in his lap. "It's not a problem, Big Brother."

Tomura leaned back and exhaled through his nose. As quiet fell over them, the anger inside of Izuku grew more sinister. It began to grow claws and showed its teeth. He squeezed his hands to keep from lashing out as he reflected on the last five years in a new light.

And when Zen returned, Izuku saw his brother and father for what they truly were: snakes.

Tomura and Zen had no humanity.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When they finished, they left the library in a perfect triangle formation. The whole way downstairs, Izuku idly walked behind them. There was no room to walk beside them, and frankly, Zen looked happy that he couldn't.

Izuku gazed ahead at the two of them, strolling side by side. In an eerie perfect way, it was like gazing through a looking glass of an older and younger version of the same person.

They both possessed hair of pure, chilling white. Zen's was obviously from age. But Izuku wondered how Tomura's hair got so pale. He still remembered when it used to be black before it lost its color and turned a bluish grey.

Now, it looked as empty as his heart.

They made their way to the exit downstairs, and Izuku stopped at the door. He looked down at his ankle bracelet idly. Tomura did as well. Zen began typing on his phone.

"I won't be back for breakfast," Tomura announced. "I'm going to let you and Kai have it to yourselves. Make sure to go over everything we said and put on your best face."

Izuku nodded dully. "Will do."

Tomura waded in silence for a moment. He looked at him with an unreadable expression and pressed his lips into a thin, thoughtful line.

"…Do you want me to come back to check in at the end of the day?" He suddenly asked.

"Sure," Izuku replied emptily.

"Okay. I'll see you then."

He stepped forward, and so did the Viper guards and Zen.

Two Yakuza guards opened the large doors, and in poured sunlight so radiant it felt wrong. Izuku watched, expressionless, as they both left. Zen didn't bother to look behind him, but as they got halfway away and the doors began to close, Tomura glanced over his shoulder.

The two brothers held gazes as the large doors slammed shut.

From beyond the doors, Izuku could faintly hear Zen talk.

"Keep him under control by any means possible," he warned. "We don't need him screwing things up again."

When the voices of Tomura and Zen were no longer there, Izuku's mask dropped straight to the ground. His eyes darkened and his fists curled. He leered at the door as his hands began to tremble.

As his anger rose, he thought back to before he defected.

He landed on one particular day. It was a few days prior to his reunion with Katsuki and a time when Katsuma was still trapped in this hell. He recalled the vision of a giant viper made of stone, slithering around in endless circles. It endlessly ate its own tail with the help of new additions to keep it growing. The body grew longer with the help of every kid trapped in their system.

Back then, he viewed the person sitting at the head of the snake to be Tomura.

But really, it was Zen.

Tomura was simply his prodigy, much like Nine was before him. Zen's poisonous ways had spread to Tomura, exactly like they spread to Nine and to everyone who ever entered his Viper Academy. The poison even spread to *him*.

Zen had infected them all, damning for the sake of his own ambitions. He trapped them in this vicious cycle—just so he could profit. And a long time ago, Izuku vowed that he was going to drive a wedge straight into the cycle and snap its neck. He promised himself that he would do it, even if it was the last thing he did.

And maybe, it should be the last thing he did.

Because if he didn't, their violent history would repeat itself.

It was already doing so. With him as Inko, trapped for his looks. With Tomura as Zen, using him for personal gain. And Katsuki, killed young—exactly like his mother. It was happening all over again, without missing a beat.

Izuku wanted so badly to break this cycle, and he realized there was only one way to do so.

Both the Yakuza and Vipers alike, needed to be eradicated.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku found Ochako in the garden after that. She was dressed in outdoor gear, sitting beneath a golden gazebo, reading a small book in the cold. A pink scarf was wrapped around her throat and pink gloves were snugly on her hands as she perched on the bench.

Izuku didn't bother to find a coat. He walked out barefoot into the snow and welcomed the chilling touch of what he now knew was going to be his last winter. Slowly, he sat down next to her, admiring the snow-covered garden. He leaned back fully onto the wooden bench.

Gradually, she glanced up from her book and looked at him. She didn't mention is lack of outerwear, but concern was evident in her big brown eyes.

"Ochako, am I allowed to get a pet?" Izuku asked quietly, not taking his eyes off the snow.

"Of course," she replied. "Chisaki Kai said that anything you request should be met so you can feel comfortable. What kind of pet do you want?"

Izuku turned, and smiled at her calmly. "A mamushi snake."

☽ ☽ ᔓ ☾ ☾

Katsuki solemnly held up his wedding ring in the sunlight.

The emeralds sparkled as his heart filled with heaviness similar to stones weighting it down. It'd been several goddamn *days*. And the longer Izuku was out there, the more Katsuki felt himself unraveling. He couldn't stop thinking about where he was and what they were doing to him—

He clenched his jaw so hard it hurt.

"What's taking you so damn long, Denki?" Monoma snapped from across the room, his voice sharp with impatience.

Denki didn't even look up, his fingers were busy flying across two keyboards. "Trust me, if I could go faster, I would," he muttered, irritation simmering under his breath. "But a small tracker means a weak signal. And welding it into silver? That makes it a *nightmare* to trace."

Monoma groaned loudly and stalked over to Denki's desk. He peered at the screen like glaring would make the process faster. Within seconds, they were bickering about code, signal interference, and tracking clouds.

Across the table, Aizawa worked silently on his own laptop. He was scanning through Tokyo's sprawl for even a flicker of a lead. His face was unreadable, but his eyes told the truth: nothing yet.

The voices around him blurred into static.

Katsuki leaned back against the conference couch, careful not to tug at the IV taped to his arm. His body still felt like shit. All his limbs were weak and battered but that was nothing compared to the wreckage inside his chest.

Quietly, Katsuki spoke through the tension. “There’s nothing I can do to make this go faster?”

The room grew quiet. Everyone turned to look at him sadly.

“No,” Denki said softly, finally meeting his gaze. “I’m sorry, Bakugou. You’ve done everything you could. I promise we’ll find him. I’ve already narrowed it down to eastern Tokyo—it’s just…trial and error now.”

Aizawa spoke next. He was calm and deliberate, like handling a landmine. “If he’s with the Yakuza, they’re likely using heavy signal disruption. That’s why Chisakis’ main location has never been pinned down—they blanket their sites with scatter fields to kill GPS.”

Denki’s jaw tightened, his eyes sparking with something fierce. “If that’s true, all we need is for him to step outside their perimeter. Even for a few seconds. If he does that, I’ll get him. I swear.”

Katsuki didn’t answer right away.

His throat locked up. He stared down at the ring in his palm.

“…Okay,” he managed at last, voice cracking. “That…makes sense.”

Nobody replied. They all gave him that look. The one that stabbed stupid pity straight through his damn ribs. Then slowly they all turned back to their screens and began searching with desperation humming in the air.

Katsuki shifted, pulling the blanket tighter around his shoulders as he stared out the window at the city of Nemuro.

In the last several days, Katsuki was growing progressively restless. He thought for certain the tracker in the ring would be a sure fire way to keep Izuku safe—but it hadn’t. Maybe the only way to have kept Izuku safe was to keep Izuku *with* him. Maybe what the old violinist said about love birds was true.

Maybe they weren’t meant to be separated.

Katsuki’s self loathing struck him as he sat with this. His eyes burned with tears as he reflected on Izuku’s life. He’d been fucking trafficked at a young age and now he was being trafficked yet *again* as a bargaining piece between the Vipers and Yakuza.

It made Katsuki feel sick that he failed Izuku.

He began to ponder on ‘what-ifs’ that only fed into his cycle of depression. What if he noticed Izuku needed help sooner? What if they connected earlier? What if he never left Tokyo with his mother? So many what-ifs and so many chances to save Izuku. And he missed them all.

A sharp ringtone shattered the tense silence.

Every head snapped toward Aizawa as he answered without hesitation, putting the call on speaker.

“We found Nana,” Miruko’s voice came fast and urgent. “She said she can wait—but there’s a complication.”

Katsuki shot upright, his pulse spiking. The room tilted for a moment as he swung his wobbly legs off the couch. He clutched the IV pole for support. Then his heart hammered so violently it felt like it might tear through his ribs.

“That’s good news,” Aizawa replied, his tone flat but edged with caution. “What’s the complication?”

There was a pause. A low sound of uncertainty from Miruko. “She’s…right here. I’ll put her on.”

A new voice filled the room. It was soft, warm, and steady. “Hello?”

Katsuki froze hearing Nana for the first time. He’d never met her, but the gentleness in her voice made it feel like he had.

“This is Aizawa Shota,” he said.

“Perfect,” she replied. “It’s nice to meet you. I understand the depth of the situation. First, thank you for getting word to me—you caught me right in time. I’ve been…holding out, hoping Izuku would come.” She hesitated, and her breath cracked faintly through the speaker. “There’s something urgent I need to speak with him about. It’s regarding the children he brought to me.”

The words landed like stones in Katsuki’s gut. He flicked a glance at Aizawa, who was already staring back with the same mix of worry and confusion.

The children? What the hell happened?

“What kind of urgent?” Aizawa asked, voice like a taut wire.

“It’s safer if I explain in person,” Nana said softly, urgency lacing her calm. “But for now—I’ve sent my apprentice, Yagi, ahead with the people who needed to leave Japan immediately. I’ll wait for you all in Okinawa as planned. Any idea when you can get to me?”

Aizawa’s gaze lifted to the massive tracking map glowing on the wall. His pause was heavy. “…No. We’re still working to pinpoint his location for extraction. When we do, you’ll be the first to know. Is there a deadline?”

“No,” Nana said firmly. “Given the situation, I’ll wait as long as I have to.”

“Understood,” Aizawa replied. “Is there a secure line we can reach you on?”

“Yes.” She rattled off the number, and Monoma scrawled it down in a blur of motion. There was a soft exhale on the other end before she spoke again. “Please—keep me updated.”

A shuffle, and then Miruko’s voice returned. “We’ll handle the rest on our end and regroup in four days. We’ll see you then.”

Aizawa gave a low grunt of acknowledgment before the line clicked dead. But just before it did, Katsuki heard something. It was a faint, wavering sound bleeding through the background. It nearly sounded like a child crying.

The noise clung to him long after the call ended. He stared at the phone, confusion knotting with relief in his chest. Finally, something shifted in their favor. One piece had fallen into place. But the piece that mattered most—the one he cared about—was still missing.

Monoma drifted over as Aizawa murmured something to Denki. He lowered himself into the seat beside Katsuki and studied him with a cautious glance.

“At least it’s something,” Monoma said finally, voice hushed.

Katsuki gave a stiff nod. “Yeah.”

The silence that followed was dense, suffocating, thick enough to choke on. Both of them stared at the floor like it might offer answers the maps and monitors couldn’t.

“…How are you holding up?” Monoma’s voice barely broke the stillness.

Katsuki didn’t look at his colleague. Instead his eyes gazed down at the wedding ring in his hand. His thoughts spiraled back to the horrifying power imbalance he witnessed between Izuku and his brother at the gravesite.

“I’m…” The word snagged in his throat. He forced it out anyway, even though his voice cracked like glass. “…Terrified.”

His fingers closed around the band, digging it into his palm until the edges bit into his skin. He hoped that his pain could bridge distance.

Maybe if he bled hard enough, Izuku would feel it and know he wasn’t alone.

☽ ☽ ᔓ ☾ ☾

The next morning, Izuku cradled the ruby wedding ring in his hands. Its warmth grounded him as if Katsuki was right there holding his him as he watched Ochako carefully bring in his new ‘pet’.

Two Yakuza servants carried a terrarium larger than anything he had ever seen. It was a perfect miniature ecosystem within glass walls. Branches twisted elegantly, leaves rustled softly, and a warm lamp cast a gentle glow over the enclosure. A fine mist clung to the glass and droplets sliding lazily downwards.

Inside, the Mamushi slithered with grace. Its scales caught the light like molten metal. Its piercing eyes were calculating, tracking him immediately. The snake's gaze was hypnotic, intelligent, and dangerous all at once.

"Set it right there," Ochako instructed, and the servants obeyed. They placed the terrarium carefully by the window where sunlight filtered in. "Perfect!" she said, clasping her hands together, her face alight with joy.

Izuku approached, standing beside her as they both observed the Mamushi.

The snake twisted sinuously around its enclosure, exploring its new domain with cautious curiosity. Izuku's chest tightened; his mind spun behind his calm exterior.

"I never realized how beautiful Mamushis are," Ochako gasped softly, leaning in to watch the creature. Her voice carried a mix of awe and delight. "Did you request this because it's your family namesake?"

"Something like that," Izuku responded.

They lingered together in silence, each absorbed in their own reasons for watching the snake. To Ochako, it was simple admiration; to Izuku, it was the key to ending an endless cycle of pain.

"What are you going to name it?" She asked.

Izuku pressed his lips in a thin, contemplative line.

"It doesn't need a name," he said. He then turned to Ochako and met her eyes. "Can we keep this between us? I don't want my brother or father to know I asked for a pet…they're not exactly fond of animals."

Ochako nodded, her smile warm and reassuring.

"Of course, Izuku," she said happily.

They both leaned up and then a heavier silence followed them. The ticking of the clock in the room stretched on, and with every passing second both off their faces fell further and further.

"It's almost time for breakfast," Ochako muttered, nearly mournful.

Izuku stiffened. The ticking from the clock now felt louder. He nodded and his eyes grew distant.

"Will he be joining?" He asked.

Ochako replied reluctantly, "Yes. He will."

The lump in Izuku's throat tightened. But he held himself steady as he clutched the ring in his fist tighter.

He looked at the snake in front of him one more time. The plan inside of his head was beginning to become real and the resentful, vengeful fire inside of his heart grew stronger.

He turned to Ochako and solemnly gazed at her.

He said with a sad smile, “What should I wear that would make him happiest?”

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku walked down with Ochako wearing a perfectly curated outfit in all black that held the Chisaki family emblem on the back. He cleaned himself up enough to look less grief stricken and appealing and pampered his face with enough light make up to enhance his features.

When he reached the dining hall, Izuku paused in the doorway.

Chisaki Kai was already present. He sat regally at the head of the long, lacquered table.

The morning light caught the sharp angles of his pale face and the glint of gold cufflinks. His posture in his all black pinstriped suit was deeply apathetic, nearly bored. A plate of grilled fish, rice, and pickled vegetables had been placed in front of him, steam rising delicately, yet he didn’t touch a bite.

His golden eyes flicked toward the door.

“Ah, finally,” Chisaki said smoothly. His lips curled into a smug smile. “I was beginning to think you’d prefer to sleep through breakfast instead of joining me.”

Izuku stepped inside, keeping his expression neutral. The ruby wedding band in his pocket was a constant weight against his hip, reminding him of what was stolen from him. He bowed slightly, low enough to show respect but high enough to keep his pride intact.

“Good morning,” Izuku greeted quietly. “Sorry to keep you waiting.”

Chisaki leaned back and jutted his chin to the seat on his left. “You can make it up by joining me.”

Izuku walked fully into the room, and Ochako and the other servers blended into the sides. Izuku glanced back at her once, noticing that her bubbly personality faded away in Chisaki Kai’s presence. She kept her eyes down, not daring to look at him.

He sank into the chair as a server quietly set down his meal, placing the utensils with precise care.

They began eating in companionable silence, punctuated by stolen glances and lingering looks. Izuku forced himself to eat for the first time in a long time, and he immediately felt the ache in his stomach. When he felt a touch too sick, he placed down his utensils and neatly folded his hands in his lap.

The air between them hummed with tension, so Izuku decided to break the silence first.

“Did you enjoy your business trip?” he asked, tilting his head slightly as he spoke. “I hope it went well.”

Chisaki shrugged, a smirk tugging at his lips.

“It did,” he said smoothly, his tone tinged with amusement. “I won’t bore you with the details if it’s not your thing.”

Izuku’s mind flicked through the list Zen and Tomura drilled into him. One of Chisaki Kai’s favorite topics was his business exploits. He deeply enjoyed bragging, though he needed to be cautious about the details around outsiders. However, among the Vipers, he loosened his tongue and let his ego show freely.

Izuku saw his first move in a long, delicate game.

“Not at all,” Izuku replied, masking the tight knot in his chest with an innocent smile. “I’d love to hear about it, if you don’t mind. I’ve always appreciated hearing the stories behind your work.”

Chisaki’s eyes flickered, and it was all the encouragement he needed. The Yakuza Heir leaned back slightly, beginning to regale Izuku with his trip. His voice carried a practiced mix of arrogance and charm as he described the deference of his business partners. He mused about how they kissed his ring and complied with his parents’ every whim.

He then went on to talk about the entertainment—the killing of a man who dared speak illy of the Chisaki family. It seemed like his new business partner thought it would be a great way to get on the Chisakis’ good side to have the man’s tongue cut out in front of them.

And it worked.

“Overall, it was a great time,” Chisaki concluded, reclining in his chair. He let his eyes linger over Izuku’s form, scanning the neat line of his clothing. The subtle intensity of his gaze made Izuku stiff slightly, though he kept his composure.

“And you?” Chisaki asked, boring his eyes into Izuku’s. “How was your stay here? I hope you were made comfortable.”

“I was,” Izuku replied, forcing warmth into his tone despite the hatred in his chest. “Thank you for thinking of my comfort. I truly appreciated it. The last few days I took to adjusting to being here, but it was pleasant.”

Chisaki arched an eyebrow. His eyes narrowed slightly in mock suspicion.

“And you are adjusted now?” he asked, his voice low and testy. “No more running away from me?”

“No more running away,” Izuku reassured. “Sorry for all the trouble I caused you, Kai. Please allow me to make it up to you.”

Chisaki's grin broadened, and his smugness became palpable. But as he did, Izuku noted there was an undercurrent of excitement in the man's posture.

"Perfect," he said, voice dripping with self-satisfaction. "I have a great few weeks ahead of us planned."

"Like what?" Izuku asked.

"You'll see," Chisaki replied, dripping control.



The rest of the day unfolded in a way Izuku hadn't expected. He had braced himself for unwanted advances and hands pulling him toward some sort of intimacy he wanted no part of. But Chisaki did something far worse: he courted him like a gentleman.

He was polite, and perfectly in control, like a real prince would be.

It was almost disarming. Almost.

Izuku kept his mask in place. Every smile he gave was calculated, and every glance he spared was measured. He kept his tone innocence and his posture modest—right in a way he knew Chisaki would love. His entire body language was curated to show a naivety he no longer felt inside his heart. But he threaded his words with just enough hesitance to seem shy without appearing unwilling.

And of course, Chisaki lapped it up like a damn dog in designer gloves.

Their first stop was the kitchen. It gleamed with marble counters and copper pots that shone under the warm lights. Chisaki moved through the space with comfortable confidence. His hands stayed clasped lightly behind his back as if strolling through a gallery rather than a room of servants scrambling to attention.

"I need to select a wine for my aunt in Italy," he said. "I'd be honored to have you assist me, Izuku."

Izuku offered a practiced smile and tilted his head just so. "Of course. I'd be happy to."

Chisaki gestured for a servant to present an array of bottles. Each one was an artifact of wealth and taste, their labels inscribed in various European scripts.

They began to sample them one by one in crystal glasses. Izuku held each to his lips, his throat burning with the dry bite of reds he secretly despised. He masked the flicker of distaste with a shy sip, lowering his lashes in a show of feigned demureness.

"Are you enjoying the tasting?" Chisaki asked, watching him closely over the rim of his own glass.

“I am.” Izuku’s voice remained airy, casual. “A sister of mine used to collect wines like these. She had me taste a lot of them.”

“Then I was right to have you help me pick some out,” Chisaki remarked with a low chuckle. He snapped his fingers once, a sharp sound that made the kitchen still. “These two,” he ordered, indicating a rare dessert wine and a pale, expensive white.

The servants moved in hurried silence to box them.

“I knew you’d have exquisite taste,” Chisaki added, smiling in a way that almost looked warm.

Izuku inclined his head, forcing his lips to soften in gratitude.

From there, they drifted deeper into the estate. Their footsteps echoed through halls lined with gold-framed art and heavy velvet drapes. During his isolation, Izuku learned the estate’s layout well enough. But when they turned toward a wing guarded by four men in black, he found himself in unfamiliar territory.

Several times, he’d been turned away whenever he wandered into this exact hall.

But now, it seemed like that wouldn’t be the case. The moment the guards saw Chisaki approach, they stepped aside like tall reeds bowing in the wind. Without a word, they pushed open the pair of towering doors.

“This,” Chisaki announced, his voice dipping with pride, “is my private wing of the estate.”

Izuku stepped inside, and for a moment, it was like being swallowed whole by Chisaki’s ego. The rooms beyond were drenched in gold, ivory, and obsidian, every surface curated to reflect extravagance. Silk screens painted with coiling dragons and chrysanthemums divided the space. Heavy chandeliers spilled pools of amber light across floors of polished stone.

“What do you think of it?” Chisaki asked, eying Izuku. “I wanted it to reflect the regal nature of my family.”

“You certainly succeeded,” Izuku murmured, letting his tone wobble slightly with awe. It wasn’t entirely an act; he was stunned by the arrogance.

Chisaki offered a smile, jutting his head toward a pair of glass doors. “Come. There’s something I’d like you to see.”

From there, Chisaki led him to another pair of doors. They stepped into an indoor greenroom garden so pristine it felt unreal. It stretched four times the size of the estate’s front grounds, blooming in defiance of winter’s grip. Rare orchids in colors too vivid to be natural spilled from stone planters, and pines rose like emerald spires against a backdrop of pale snow.

“Beautiful, isn’t it?” Chisaki asked softly.

“Yes,” Izuku replied, forcing his lips into a delicate curve.

Like a cage lined with flowers, he thought bitterly.

Next came the art room. Its walls were lined with half-finished canvases and delicate porcelain vases. Izuku was taken back, not expecting this. He walked in slowly, fully mystified by the various figurative paintings lying on the ground and leaning against the walls. He strolled up to one in particular and felt an eerie stare looking back at him.

In a small pile were portrait paintings of him.

Izuku stopped dead in his tracks.

"I find painting…*clarifying*," Chisaki explained. He came up behind him, casting a cold shadow over Izuku as he leaned in to whisper in his ear. "When everything around you feels chaotic, creating order brings peace. I like to paint what I most desire."

Izuku looked at his own green eyes staring back at him.

He swallowed.

Lunch followed after several more room tours. They settled in the reading room, and servants brought them trays bearing dishes that were both intricate and excessive. They ate in quiet, save for the low crackle of an occasional murmur from Chisaki.

Afterward, the servants drew a table set for Shōgi for them along with more wine for them to enjoy.

In the end, Izuku let Chisaki win. Five times.

Each game, the Yakuza Heir's smile sharpened at the edges. His ego was practically on display as he gleamed with the idea of outwitting Izuku.

"You'll get the hang of it soon," Chisaki chuckled. He poured more wine into their glasses without asking.

Izuku hesitated when the ruby liquid caught the light. He didn't want it. But he took the glass anyway, bowing his head in silent thanks before bringing it to his lips. The bitterness struck hard, but he swallowed it down.

And through it all, Chisaki never once reached for him. Never pressed. Never lingered too close. He was pleasant as though they were simply two companions passing an idle afternoon.

It was as if Izuku hadn't run halfway across the country to escape him.

And it pissed Izuku off.

Chisaki moved as though Katsuki's death was merely a small price for this charade.

The thought seared through him like acid.

By the time they rose from the table, the sky begun to blush with sunset. Orange bled into rose across the horizon and light spilled through the high windows. They walked in silence for a time and their shadows stretched across the polished floors.

For a moment, Izuku almost believed the day would end without consequence. Maybe Chisaki truly wanted nothing from him but conversation.

Until they stopped.

Another set of double doors loomed before them—doors unlike the others. They were black and etched with curling veins of gold. The surface was marked by the Shie Hassaikai crest at the center.

Izuku paused.

He turned his gaze to Chisaki, whose amber eyes gleamed in the dimming light.

“What room is this?” Izuku asked.

“A surprise,” Chisaki replied. A faint, taut smile tugged on his lips. “Go on. Step in.”

Izuku took a careful look. Then suddenly, the air shifted. It was here he glanced back at the Yakuza guards that had been trailing them all day. He noted they stopped further down the corridor than they’d done previously. Izuku glanced once at Chisaki again, and his skin crawled.

He stepped inside first, back to the other man. It was dark inside, but in the dim light of the setting sun, Izuku could see what this was.

It was Chisaki’s bedroom.

The door locked behind him.

Izuku turned, and his heart hammered loudly in his ears. He looked at the Yakuza Heir who followed behind him. The tall, crow-like man strolled inside with unhurried grace. He kept his posture regal like he knew every inch of the world bent to his will.

He removed his gloves with meticulous precision. First the left, then the right. He snapped the leather gently before setting them on the table by his door.

That small sound was louder than the pounding in Izuku’s skull.

Izuku offered a shallow nod, pulse hammering against his ribs.

Smile. Keep calm. Breathe. He summoned the faintest curve to his lips.

Chisaki hummed to him a low, approving sound that curled like smoke.

He moved closer, slow and deliberate, loosening the knot of his tie as he crossed the space. Each step hit against Izuku's nerves, dragging him toward the moment he'd dreaded since the day he learned of Tomura selling his virginity.

"You've been very sweet today," Chisaki said as he nearly closed the space between them. His hand lifted, fingers brushing a stray curl from Izuku's forehead with disquieting tenderness. "It was everything I hoped for when this arrangement was first planned out—but you've been *very* hard to catch. You're lucky I like the thrill of a chase."

Izuku swallowed hard as Chisaki's hand began to wander. As they did, the room felt smaller. The walls inched closer with every second as he could smell the dark musk of the other man's cologne.

Then Chisaki's fingers trailed down his jaw, slow and possessive.

"However, this cat-and-mouse game," he murmured, his voice dipping silk-smooth as his fingers curled beneath Izuku's chin, tilting it up, "is officially over."

And then he moved.

Izuku barely had time to register what was happening before Chisaki's body pressed flush against his. Lips crashed against his throat. Greedy fingers grazed his sensitive skin as kisses burned trails down his neck, leaving him shuddering with revulsion.

Izuku jerked back, a reflexive shock tearing through him. But Chisaki followed, relentlessly. One step, two, and Izuku's spine struck wood with a muted thud. The dresser rattled against the wall as the heir loomed over him like a shadow.

His shirt yanked open in one brutal tug, buttons breaking and baring his chest to the chill of the room. Izuku gritted his teeth and his eyes widened as his instinct screamed to break Chisaki's bones until he was nothing but pieces—but Izuku forced his fingers to curl against the dresser instead of Chisaki's throat.

"W-Wait—" Izuku's voice trembled like glass under strain. "Kai, wait—"

"Izuku," Chisaki hissed against his Adam's apple. "I'm *done* waiting."

Panic ricocheted through Izuku's skull. His training surged up like a lifeline, whispering tactics through the static in his brain. His lips parted, and before the moment could break, the lie slipped out.

"Please—I-I'm still a virgin."

"I'm *well* aware," he said curtly, impatience licking at the edges of his words. "Don't worry. I'm experienced enough for both of us." His tone darkened, final. "Now, relax."

He seized Izuku by the wrists and flung him toward the bed. Izuku landed hard, and the mattress swallowed his grunt as he scrambled upright. He yanked his shirt closed over his exposed skin. His heart skipped in his chest, a frantic warning drum as Chisaki shrugged off his blazer, movements slow and predatory.

A sneer carved across his face as he stood at the foot of the bed.

“I’m not fond of forcing myself on people—especially trained assassins.” His eyes glinted coldly. “But Izuku, you’ve been testing my kindness for *months*. If I have to signal my guards to come in here and hold you down for me, I will do it.”

“I-I don’t want to have sex until I’m married!” Izuku blurted out.

Chisaki paused. Then he frowned. “What?”

Izuku forced himself to meet Chisaki’s gaze while his heart tried to claw out of his chest.

“That’s the reason wh-why I never had sex,” he whispered, voice breaking at the edges. “A-and the reason I’ve been so resistant to this arrangement—” He swallowed hard. “I always thought my first time would be…after I got married.”

The silence was thick enough to drown in.

Chisaki didn’t move. He didn’t even blink.

Izuku could feel the weight of every second pressing down on him. He scrambled upright and flitted his eyes to every corner of the large room to avoid looking at the man in front of him.

“I…” His throat closed, but he pushed through. “I-I’m a hopeless romantic.”

“Your brother mentioned that a long time ago, yes,” Chisaki confirmed testily. “Why are you saying this now?”

“Because life as a Viper is…bleak,” Izuku confessed.

He swallowed when his heart began to become heavier. Truth slipped into his act as he felt the weight of the ring in his pocket.

“And the only real thing I had to hold on to was wanting my first time to mean something. I thought it would be beautiful if I belonged to someone who really loved me—” A visual of Katsuki smiling appeared in his mind. His breath hitched and rawness cracked through his emotional mask. “—th-then maybe I could have the fairy tale romance I’ve always dreamed about.”

A single tear slipped loose, hot against his cheek.

It wasn’t staged. It wasn’t part of the script. It was Katsuki, pulsing in his heart even now.

Chisaki fell away slowly, like he was pulling back from a precipice. His eyes turned unreadable as he tracked the tear rolling down Izuku’s face.

His voice came flat and even. “You really believe that, don’t you?”

Izuku nodded stiffly. “I do.”

Chisaki exhaled through his nose, the sound was almost like a laugh but stripped of humor. He turned slightly, paced a few steps, and folded his hands behind his back.

A long silence stretched, coiling tighter with every beat of Izuku's heart.

Then finally, Chisaki spoke.

"I've been very patient with you," he said curtly. "More patient than I've ever been with *anyone*. I wondered for a while why I cared so much about a mindless Viper—no matter how beautiful you were. I kept telling myself to drop it, and move on to someone who knows their place. But there's something about you that I can't seem to let go of."

He turned back around, and there was a possessive glint in his gaze.

"And now I see why," he finished.

Izuku stayed perfectly still as Chisaki approached again.

"You're not like others," Chisaki continued, voice low and intrigued. "Not a normal Viper. Not a common…plaything." His hand lifted, brushing lightly over Izuku's cheek, tracing the line of the tear. "You're truly pure. And I've been searching for someone like that my whole life."

Izuku's stomach knotted. He lowered his lashes to feign embarrassment.

"At the masquerade, you said you were going to make our time together romantic for me," he whispered. "I was looking forward to that before it all fell apart."

Chisaki studied him for a moment, then let his hand drop.

"I did say that, didn't I?" he murmured. "Interesting. You have the kind of dignity a Yakuza spouse would hold for themselves. I always assumed Vipers obeyed orders without thinking—but yet. Here you are, giving me a *boundary*."

Izuku's heart thudded and dread swirled in his chest.

"I'll have to take some time to consider this," Chisaki continued, tone smooth. "A man like me doesn't rush. I'll have to weigh whether this want of yours is valid given our arrangement—seeing as I have already paid your brother a very hefty bill for you."

"Of course," Izuku breathed.

And when Chisaki leaned in, Izuku froze. He thought he was going in for a kiss, but instead Chisaki pressed his lips to Izuku's knuckles. The heat from the gesture rippled through the room as Chisaki's predatory eyes burned into his.

He leaned away with a limerence stricken gaze and smiled.

"Let's get you back to your room."

They walked in silence, their footsteps echoing against the polished corridor.

Izuku clutched his half-open shirt shut with one trembling hand, his knuckles white against the black fabric. The chill of the hallway brushed against his bare skin, but it wasn't the cold that made him shiver.

Beside him, Chisaki strode with his hands folded neatly behind his back. His gaze wandered down every so often, lingering without shame on the tanned column of Izuku's exposed throat.

When they reached the door to Izuku's bedroom, both men paused. Their eyes met in the dim light pooling from the chandeliers above.

"I'll see you at breakfast tomorrow," Chisaki said.

He smiled tightly, and his eyes drifted down to Izuku's neck.

Izuku bowed and forced a smile. "Looking forward to it. Sleep well, Kai."

"Same for you."

And with that, Chisaki departed with the two guards who shadowed him. They disappeared down the long hallway and Izuku walked into his room.

When the door clicked shut, Izuku's smile instantly crumbled.

His hand trembled as it rose to his neck—where Chisaki's rough lips dragged over his skin. He felt an invisible stain left there, and he knew it couldn't be scrubbed away. It made him feel *filthy*. Without warning, a blistering mix of rage and humiliation surged up his throat.

His fingers clenched, nails biting into his flesh as though he could scratch out the memory.

Soon, the tears came fast. They blurred his vision until the room swam in shadows. He bit down hard on his lip. He tasted iron, but he refused to let a sound escape. His anger was molten now, flooding through his veins until his soul reshaped under the weight of it. His chest heaved, his jaw locked, and his bitter tears spilled freely.

He turned, eyes full of resentment.

Across the room, the mamushi snake was coiled in its glass prison. Its golden eyes glinted in the dark like two shards of malice.

For an instant, in the reflection of that glass, Izuku thought he saw Katsuki looking back at him.

His face twisted. The grief in his expression contorted into vengeance. He wiped his tears with the back of his hand, leaving streaks across his flushed skin as he crossed the room to the cage.

Izuku knelt, reaching under the stand for the jar he hid earlier.

It was a small, clear vessel capped with a thin sheet of parchment stretched taut and secured with twine. His pulse spiked as he slid the lid off the cage.

The snake hissed, low and threatening. The sound slithered straight into his bones. But Izuku didn't flinch. He slid both hands inside. He kept himself steady merely with the thought of Katsuki. As his mind filled with the memories of his dead husband, it was as if Katsuki was helping hold his hands still and confident so he could do what needed to be done.

Immediately, the creature struck instantly. Its fangs flashed and its jaws snapped for flesh. Izuku jerked his wrist back with sharp reflex, twisting to seize the serpent's body in one swift, merciless grip.

It writhed furiously. Its scales rasped against his skin, and its muscles coiled like steel wire as it fought against him. The tail lashed, curling tight around his forearm in a crushing spiral. But Izuku held his ground. His grip clamped down on the narrow head, fingers pinning it in an iron vise. The snake hissed louder. Its mouth began yawning wide, and its fangs gleamed wet in the dim light.

"Shh," Izuku soothed gently.

With surgical precision, he pressed two fingers along its skull to force the jaws apart, exposing the venomous needles within.

Slowly, he lowered its head towards the jar. The parchment dented under pressure as he guided the fangs through the thin membrane.

A moment of resistance. Then the paper tore, and the venom flowed.

Drop by glistening drop, pale yellow-green venom bled into the glass.

The sharp, acrid smell hit him. It mimicked a scent similar to a mixture of rust and rot, making his stomach knot. As the poison flowed, the snake hissed and thrashed, but Izuku kept steady. He watched without blinking as the liquid gathered into a tiny pool.

When the last drop fell, Izuku eased the serpent back into its cage with the same deliberate care. He slid the lid shut, and exhaled shakily.

In the dim light, the venom gleamed.

It spoke to him, whispering a promise of freedom and a clear path to end this cycle of agony. A strange mix of revulsion and fascination churned in Izuku's stomach. And soon, cold sweat slicked his palms from a spike of anxiety. His heart hammered against his ribs, a frantic warning urging him to look away. But he couldn't. His eyes remained glued to the viscous liquid.

Izuku lifted the jar to his face.

In the glass, he saw not his own reflection but the ghost of beautiful scarlet eyes.



Art by @popiloboo

Chapter End Notes

Let me know what you think below :') I re-wrote and restructured this chapter and the next about 5 times. Balancing Izuku's descent into hatred/vengeance was surprisingly more complex than other element in this story. Its sad to think our little pink loving man is dressing in all black :'(

It's about to get very chaotic!!

Thank you so much for reading <3 <3

Chapter 45: Prestissimo

Chapter Summary

> Prestissimo (Tempo) — As fast as possible

Chapter Notes

> Hellooo!! :) Thank you guys so much for all your comments and theories! I've been SUPER excited to finally get to this section of the story! Wow what a crazy time its about to be :D
>
> First, thank you to the LOML Luna for Betaing <3 And now without further wait, I hope you enjoy the chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 45 — Prestissimo

.

.

.

Izuku sat forward, back hunched and shoulders tight.

He concentrated on the notebook in front of him. His eyebrows furrowed, and his hands rattled with a slight tremble. His gaze never left the page as he scraped the pencil across the surface.

“Lecithin…” Izuku muttered under his breath, “An emulsifier to help proteins pass through the gut-lining. Then a low dose of an acid to act as a corrosive agent and burn a hole in the gastrointestinal barrier.” A pause. His eyes slid over to the jar of venom, and measured it quietly. “But I would need something that would let the toxin seep into the bloodstream. Venom isn’t lethal through digestion alone.”

He glanced at the snake, and its bright eyes glowed in the dark.

When it coiled onto itself, inspiration struck. Izuku’s eyes snapped down to the paper and he hurriedly wrote the last thing he would need.

“Dimethyl sulfoxide,” he whispered with finality.

He leaned back and stared at the mess of words. The yellow tint from the lamp next to his bed spread across his hasty handwriting. As he read it back, pressure pushed unrelenting tears against his eyes.

This was really it.

Suddenly, a sharp knock split the stillness of the room.

Izuku jolted. His back straightened, and his gut dropped.

“Izuku?” Tomura’s muffled voice carried across the heavy door. “Are you in there?”

“I—I am!” Izuku called back. “Just give me a second.”

He scrambled upright and shoved the notepad under his pillow. He smoothed the sheets, erasing any sign of what he’d been doing. When he was sure nothing incriminating remained in sight, he cracked the door open and slipped through, pulling it firmly shut.

In the hallway, his big brother stood tall, and he looked exceptionally drained. Tomura’s coat hung against his frame, black as ink with the faint sheen of melted snow. And his eyes were undercut with deep shadows.

“Sorry I’m so late,” he said, voice low with apology. “I know I promised I’d be back after dinner, but meetings stacked up.”

Izuku nodded once. “It’s okay.”

His voice was thinner than he aimed for. But he couldn’t summon the energy to wear the mask any longer. The facade with Chisaki drained him dry. Every smile and flutter of his eyelashes cost him more than he ever thought.

“How’d the day with Chisaki go?” Tomura asked after a breathing space.

“It went well,” Izuku replied mechanically.

His gaze slid away toward the frost-laced window. He couldn’t look at Tomura—not with the taste of humiliation still burning at the back of his throat.

A quietness passed through them. Izuku kept his eyes on the windowpane while Tomura kept his eyes on him. A question was coming, and Izuku could sense the heavy anticipation of it in the air.

When Tomura finally spoke, his tone was delicate. “Did you two…?”

“No,” Izuku quickly replied. He shook his head and cleared his throat, biting back all the disgust from where he could still feel Chisaki’s lips at his neck. “I’m going to withhold intimacy until the wedding night. I think it’ll push him along to the idea of permanently acquiring me.”

“That’s a smart angle,” Tomura said with a note of admiration.

“I figured it would play into his obsession with purity,” Izuku continued. “He says he’ll weigh things out. But I’ll keep his attention as planned. I want to make sure I accelerate things as fast as possible, like One wanted.”

“You did good,” Tomura praised. There was an inch of happiness in his voice, but so was apprehension. “You’ve always been smart.”

“Thank you.”

“And how is fixing your tolerance going?”

“It’s going,” Izuku lied. He hugged his arms and pressed his lips in a thin line. “I feel sick to the stomach most days but—it’s building back to where it was.”

“Expected. I’ll bring you some medicine for stomach ulcers tomorrow.”

Izuku didn’t have it in him to give another reply. He could feel the last of his mask slip, and grief demanded his attention. His body felt heavier, and his eyes dropped low. The back of his throat pushed with tears as he struggled to keep it together.

“I’m…tired,” Izuku rasped. He held his arms tighter to his body. “Is it okay if I go to bed?”

“Of course.”

He didn’t move right away. But he didn’t speak again. When Izuku finally glanced up, their eyes met. His brother was studying him, silently cataloging his body language.

“Do you think you could convince Chisaki within the next three weeks?” Tomura asked. “One is anxious about the financial issues we’re going to face when spring comes.”

“I could.” Izuku grew quieter. “Three weeks is enough time.”

Tomura nodded, lingered another beat, and then stepped back.

“Good night, Izuku,” he said quietly. “I’ll check in tomorrow.”

“Good night.”

Tomura turned, allowing himself to be swallowed up by the shadows. Once he was gone, Izuku slipped back into his room and shut the door. He twisted the lock until it clicked. Then his hand stayed there. His body sagged forward and his forehead rested against the cold wood.

When he opened his eyes again, the darkness surrounding him felt deeper.

ᔓᔓᔓ

The next morning, Izuku ate breakfast alone with Chisaki. The servants were in the corners with their heads down, and the snowfall outside looked heavier. Chisaki was eating slowly, patting the greasy residue off his lips between bites. Izuku thought for a moment he wasn't going to speak to him, given the previous night. But he was proven wrong.

"I've decided to take your stance seriously," Chisaki announced. He took a gulp of water and then looked Izuku in the eye calmly. "I suppose it's not a bad thing to want to wait until marriage."

Izuku blinked, masking his surprise with neutrality. "You have?"

"Yes." A slight shrug. "At first, I thought your hopeless romantic nature was naïve. Endearing, perhaps, but overall impractical. But after some thought—" His gloved hands folded neatly on the table as he leaned back. "—Now, I see the value in it."

His eyes flared faintly as he spoke, cold and unnaturally golden in the pale morning light.

"You see, the reason I admire purity is because my world is drowning in corruption," Chisaki explained. "Every day, I am surrounded by greedy, selfish people. They are all entirely predictable. But worse, they bore me. But someone truly untainted? Someone whose heart has not rotted from ambition or filth?"

He leaned forward, his eyes burning with desire.

"That," he whispered, voice much lower, "is rare. And rare things fascinate me. I can't predict them. I can't control them entirely. And that unpredictability?" His lips curved upwards. "It is intoxicating."

Izuku forced himself to hold the ensnaring eye contact.

"A counterbalance," he replied. "You want someone who feels like a breath of fresh air."

The smirk on Chisaki's face widened.

"Exactly," he said, savoring the word. "I want someone to show me something different. Someone that can make me feel something other than boredom."

"I can do that," Izuku replied. He leaned in enough to mimic sincerity. "I'd love the chance to get to know you better, Kai."

Chisaki chuckled, clearly flattered. He tilted his head and raked his eyes without shame up and down Izuku's body.

He then spoke, "But I will say, if I'm not convinced in at least a month that you are genuinely marriage material—I'll have my way with you and have you discarded after." The smirk on his face flipped insidiously. "I don't want it to come to that, but I'm sure you understand I have to make sure I get my money's worth in the end."

Izuku's smile faltered for less than a second.

But Chisaki didn't notice.

"Of course," Izuku agreed. "I understand."

☽ ☽ ෆ ☾ ☾

"I'm done fucking waiting around."

Katsuki violently ripped the IV out of his arm. He hissed as blood welled in tiny, angry beads. The pain blistered instantly, but he pushed through it because it was nothing compared to the growing worry gnawing in his gut.

Instantly, Aizawa and Sero tried to calm him down. But he wasn't having it. He grabbed the IV pole to help him upright and rose to his feet. With a curse, Aizawa crossed the small room and put his hands firmly on Katsuki's shoulders and forced him to sit back down.

"Bakugou," he warned. "If you push it, you're going to be in no shape to help him save him."

But Katsuki was fed up. He shook his head and shoved Aizawa's hands off of him.

"And if we keep sitting on our asses, he won't *be* there to save anymore," Katsuki hissed.

Silence blanketed the room when Aizawa didn't give a reply. Instead, the older man exhaled, low and tired, and glanced at his nephew.

The look they shared said enough: Katsuki wasn't wrong.

It'd been exactly a full day since Miruko and Shinsou returned, making it five days since Nana told them she would wait. Which meant they were nearing another full week of no answers. Who knows if Izuku was even still alive. They were going on a thread, hoping that Izuku—or whoever had the ring—stepped outside for even just a second.

And all the while, Katsuki was on the verge of tears. But every time he tried to cry and let it out, nothing came. The tension sat at the back of his throat, suffocating him in all his regrets.

Sero brought Katsuki another bottle of water. His friend sat down next to him and rubbed his back.

"I know things are tense, but you gotta hold it together," Sero tried to reason.

Katsuki closed his eyes and hung his head.

"Easier said than done," he whispered.

Their team was in limbo. After coming back from Nana, everyone pretty much began to set up camp at The Company's satellite headquarters. There were spare bedrooms upstairs, and other agents from The Company trickled in and out curiously.

It didn't take long for nearly everyone at the satellite HQ to be nosy, hoping to figure out what was going on. But Aizawa and Miruko shooed them away like flies. They told all the

other agents they were in the middle of something extremely top secret and to respect their privacy.

“Do you want to go lay down upstairs with the others?” Aizawa asked. “You could probably use a proper bed.”

Katsuki shook his head. “I feel better sleeping down here with Denki.”

He eyed the giant projection that displayed his colleague’s grueling work. It was a large map, littered with Xs showing all the places Denki ruled out. Katsuki’s heart sank further when another red X appeared, striking down yet one more place Izuku wasn’t.

He glanced at Denki, who was hunched over three monitors at once.

One displayed a map pulsing with data points. Another scrolled endlessly with green and black code that hummed across the screen. And the third flickered as it tore through CCTV feeds at a blistering pace.

Perched on his head were glaring yellow noise-canceling headphones, sealing him off from the world. He was wired in, oblivious to everything but the glow of his screens. Katsuki caught the bloodshot focus in his eyes—sharper than he’d ever seen—and the growing graveyard of empty energy drink cans scattered around him.

“Bakugou,” Sero started, slightly uneasy. He shifted uncomfortably and hesitated on his next words. “Have you considered…leaving without him?”

Katsuki’s head snapped up, and instantly his anger flared.

“Why the hell would you suggest something like that?” He growled.

Sero held up his hands and his throat bobbed. “I just—look, the Yakuza think you’re dead. That’s keeping you safe, but if they find out you’re not—” He swallowed hard. “That’s a death sentence, Bakugou. A real one. If we don’t find Izuku soon, maybe…maybe you should still disappear with Nana for your own safety. You deserve to live.”

Katsuki’s nostrils flared. He was on his feet before the suggestion even finished leaving Sero’s mouth.

“How could you say that to me?” He hissed in betrayal.

Sero’s face fell. “It’s only a suggestion. You should think about your own safety.”

“Izuku’s life is as important as mine,” Katsuki snarled. “Leaving him behind is the same as killing him. And I’m not sentencing him to death, Sero.”

With a determined glare, Katsuki grabbed the IV pole and began limping towards the door. In the background, Aizawa quickly shot a scolding, chastising remark to Sero then stopped when Katsuki’s hand reached the door knob.

“Where are you going, Bakugou?” He asked, exasperated. “You’re in no shape to wander around.”

“I’m going to get my strength back,” Katsuki spat without looking. “If we can’t find him by the time my body works again, I’ll go searching for him myself.”

He marched out the door, ignoring the calls for him to come back. Katsuki held back tears as small sprouts of pain trickled into his extremities. When he found the empty lounge upstairs, he sat down angrily.

His gaze fell to his trembling hands.

The bandages were still dark with blood and his wounds pulsated every second. The damage from clawing his way out of the coffin was worse than he’d allowed himself to believe. Every movement was stiff and every attempt at control showed how fragile his body still was.

Aizawa was right, and he hated it.

He was still too weak to even consider rescuing Izuku. But Katsuki bit down hard on the thought. He sucked in a breath and tightened his jaw as he forced his resolve deeper.

With his chin lowered and teeth clenched, he fixed every ounce of focus on the slow, deliberate act of flexing his fingers. Pain lanced through him, sharp and unforgiving. But he endured.

Step by step, again and again, he told himself to make a goddamn fist.

He could do it. He had to do it.

He repeated the motions until the sun burned itself out and darkness crept across the windows. Only when the moon hung overhead did his efforts show: a single fist, trembling in triumph.

Relief tore from his chest in a shaky breath.

When he successfully balled up both fists, he could feel a shift in the atmosphere. That small thread of hope transformed. It was stronger. Bigger. And far more defiant. It pushed aside all the doubts screaming in his head and focused on the ferocious determination to be back by Izuku’s side.

“I’m coming,” Katsuki whispered. “I promise, I’m coming.”

☽ ☽ ෧ ☾ ☾

The next two weeks blurred into a performance that chipped steadily away at Izuku’s will.

The mask he was wearing was so tight, it felt like skin. It was suffocating, but he knew it was necessary. He needed to mold himself into the shape everyone always wanted him to be.

With Chisaki Kai, he became the fantasy the man obsessed over.

Submissive. Delicate. Overly meek.

Izuku presented a version of himself that didn't exist. It was surprisingly easy to do. All he did was imagine who he'd be if he never met Katsuki. This fake self was flawless: the perfect Viper, pliant and poised in equal measure. He spoke only when spoken to and never volunteered an opinion out of turn. And when Kai talked, Izuku listened like a devoted acolyte.

He smiled at every word and laughed softly at every carefully delivered jest. He mirrored Kai's admiration so convincingly that even the Yakuza Heir himself, with all his suspicious sharpness, seemed lulled into believing it was real.

For Zen, Izuku vanished.

On the days his biological father visited, Izuku made sure to fade so far into the background that he was nothing more than a shadow against the walls. He allowed silence to consume him, knowing it pleased Zen not to hear the echo of Izuku's voice.

And for Tomura, Izuku yielded completely.

He let all his resistance seep from his bones and dissolve into the ache in his chest. The anguish hollowed him out to the point that he could be as controllable as his brother needed.

He played each part with perfect precision, using every ounce of his training and energy.

Kai believed it. Zen believed it.

But, Izuku was unsure if Tomura did.

There were moments when Izuku could feel his brother's cold eyes dissecting him. He'd look over his shoulder, and would catch Tomura boring his eyes into his soul. It was like his brother was stripping the mask from his face with his eyes alone.

Why was it that Tomura was one of the few people Izuku could never read? It was hard to tell whether or not his brother saw through the false compliance.

But if he did, he said nothing.

Tomura never pressed. Never accused. He simply observed and let his gaze linger.

And when everyone was gone, and it was only Izuku by himself in the quiet hours, he collected venom from the mamushi snake. The creature began to understand his routine, and resigned itself like some passive deity trapped in a cage. The serpent bared its teeth easily and expected nothing more than its poison to be extracted.

Soon, Izuku measured the passage of time by the amount of venom.

First it was a droplet. Then a thin film that shimmered underneath the dim light. Next, it was enough to ripple and mirror back his grief-stricken eyes. And when two and a half weeks crawled by, the jar was half full of pure death.

When he knew he collected enough, Izuku quietly asked three separate servants for a long list of mundane, useless items. Lotions. Notebooks. Baking soda. And within those things, he asked for the chemicals he needed.

He did this because he knew separately, the items drew no attention. But together, they would raise red flags.

Originally, Izuku considered asking Ochako to get the chemicals, but he quickly dismissed the idea. Over the last few days, she turned out to be a small, bright presence that offset the shadowed corridors of the estate. She was kind, clever, and empathic. The mere thought of her discovering even a hint of his plan made Izuku feel nauseous.

He didn't want her to become ensnared in his mess like Katsuki.

And because of her, he found moments to breathe. These were brief interludes of shared laughter that carried them past the oppressive walls. It began one evening, as Ochako drew his bath for him. She chuckled at the absurdity of the estate.

"This place is *lousy* with chandeliers," she whispered, smirking as she adjusted the water. "There's so many. It's ridiculous, isn't it?"

Izuku pressed a hand to his mouth, stifling his laugh. His gaze flicked to the massive golden chandelier hanging above them.

"I never noticed," he admitted, a small smile tugging at his lips. "But you're right. There really is an insane amount."

"Like, why does the bathroom downstairs have two?" Ochako leaned in, eyes crinkled with amusement. "As if these people need two chandeliers to just…*wipe*."

Izuku let the corner of his mouth lift into a grin. "They probably need two to see past their enormous egos blocking all the light."

They both erupted into restrained laughter, careful not to let their mirth carry beyond the locked door.

These moments became frequent. They would sit together on the cool bathroom floor, quietly chuckling at all the follies of the estate. Or sometimes they would simply vent about how awful the Chisaki were. Their chats gave Izuku a brief reprieve from the ache in his chest.

Other times they stayed up together in the dining hall chatting.

Ochako was very curious about his life. She inquired a lot about how he ended up here, with Chisaki Kai. And Izuku, with nothing to lose, told her everything. The lock on his throat that told him to never speak ill about his upbringing was officially gone.

"It's all for a merger," Izuku explained with dull eyes. "Everyone benefits except for me. The Vipers get respect, money, and status. The Yakuza get free protection and expand their power. And to top it off, Chisaki gets…me."

Ochako's eyes softened. "As a trophy?"

"Yeah," he said. "A beautiful trophy."

She fell silent, pity settling across her features, but it didn't linger long. She leaned in, shifting the conversation with deft curiosity toward the photos he kept. The first time she asked, Izuku was caught off guard. But over time, recounting the memories of Katsuki became a source of solace.

Which brought them to now, with Izuku sitting on the stool in front of the vanity mirror while Ochako combed his hair.

She was softening it and applying light touches of product to shape it just so. The warm glow of the room caught the soft highlights in his mane as he flipped through photographs of Katsuki. He laughed with Ochako at memories that still felt so vividly alive.

"And you two were at each other's throats for eight years?" Ochako giggled. "And neither of you realized who the other was?"

She swept his bangs back and smoothed them with a delicate hand.

"No," Izuku chuckled. "Crazy, isn't it?" He lingered on one photo of Katsuki. His dead husband was squinting against the sun with a scowl tugging at his charming face. "We were always side by side, even when we didn't know it."

"I think that's the closest thing I've ever heard to soulmates."

She patted light blush on his cheeks, deepening their rosy look. As she primped him, Izuku's eyes remained locked on the photo.

A small, wry smile tugged at his lips. "He was…really amazing."

Silence settled between them, and Ochako paused mid-motion. Her hand hovered, waiting, as if she could feel the grief on him.

"If you want to talk about something else, we can," she suggested softly.

"No," Izuku responded swiftly, shaking his head. "It's—it's okay. Talking about him makes me feel closer to him."

He flipped to another photo. Then another.

And suddenly, the grief in his chest felt heavier than before.

It wasn't that it had lessened in the days prior. Only that, for the last two weeks, Izuku managed to carry it with anger alone. His hatred for the Yakuza and the Vipers was a shield large enough to conceal himself from the burden of sorrow. Vengeance was his shelter, preventing him from drifting away into misery.

But this morning, for reasons he couldn't name, the ache pressed harder. It was insistent. It rose around him like a violent storm, battering against the windows of his shelter, rattling his cage of protection demanding to be heard.

Abruptly, an impatient knock struck against the door.

Both Izuku and Ochako jumped, and turned their heads.

"Izuku, are you ready yet?" Tomura called, annoyed. "Everyone is waiting downstairs for you."

"I'm almost ready," Izuku called back. "I just need to put my kimono on."

"Okay. You have eight minutes. Don't make the Chisakis wait long."

"Right. Of course not."

Tomura's footsteps faded, and the laughter that was once in the room was officially gone.

In the past few weeks, Tomura urged Izuku to choreograph a dance for Chisaki Kai. The performance would serve as the final link in a long chain meant to bind the man's attention to him. His brother pressed him into it because these dances always were Izuku's most reliable means of seducing marks. And, as Tomura reasoned, the language of assassination was not so different from the language of luring someone into marriage.

Izuku checked himself in the mirror once more. His skin was dewy, and his lips were tinged with the faintest pink. Ochako solemnly sprayed cologne on his wrists and neck.

Pushing down the storm in his chest, Izuku stood up and anchored himself the best that he could. The kimono on the bed stared at him, and he stared right back. It was pitch black, a shade deeper than usual, and decorated in patterns of iridescent flowers. Matching the floral pattern was an obi of pale gold, offsetting the darkness.

"Let's get you ready," Ochako suggested, mournful.

Izuku dully nodded as she began.

She wrapped him in the intricate layers, covering his body fully. Her hands cinched his obi tight, suffocating him in the name of beauty. Through the full-length mirror, Izuku observed himself transform into someone who looked like they belonged to the Shie Hassaikai.

"Are you experienced at dancing?" Ochako inquired, trying to lighten the mood.

"I trained in a lot of different styles since I was a teenager," he explained. "It's second nature at this point."

Right after Nine declared his looks were a weapon, Ibara and Jin wasted no time throwing him into the fire of seduction training. They sharpened him like a blade and sculpted his movements. His brother and sister taught him how to speak desire like it was its own dialect.

Eye contact. Flattery. The right breath at the right time.

But most importantly, they taught him how to move like a flame. They showed him how to transform into a light that was too captivating to resist. Together, the three of them practiced dance after dance. Some were sharp and slow, others playful and teasing. A few were soaked in lust.

But the most dangerous were the ones laced with elegance and subtlety.

And those worked every time without fail.

Ochako draped the heavy black haori over his shoulders, letting it fall perfectly into place. Her hands lingered briefly on his arms as she adjusted the fabric. She was careful not to disturb the smooth line of the kimono beneath.

When she stepped back, Izuku's reflection in the mirror was exactly how Tomura would have wanted it: full of allure.

Hopelessness crept up again, and the grief rattled him once more.

Carefully, Izuku tucked the necklace with his eternity ring inside of his collar.

Izuku and Ochako exchanged one wordless glance and headed out. In the hallway, Tomura was waiting for them. His brother wore a black kimono, and his long hair was tied back into a pony tail with his usual red string.

He looked Izuku up and down for a moment, and then stepped forward.

Without a word, he lifted a hand and tucked one of Izuku's stubborn curls behind his ear, like always.

"Ready?" Tomura asked, simple but commanding.

"Yeah. I'm ready," Izuku replied.

He kept his head leveled, but in the back of his mind, his grief was roaring louder and louder.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Downstairs, the private room brimmed with the Shie Hassaikai.

It was smaller than the grand halls, intimate in size. The walls were paneled in dark wood that shone under the dim lanterns. Tatami mats lined the floor in rows, creating a symmetry that framed the narrow center aisle—a strip of space that stretched forward like a ceremonial runway.

Above, a single light hung low. It cast its pale luminosity down the middle while pulling everything else into subdued shadow.

When Izuku entered, the first thing he noticed was the scent. In a terrible way, it reminded him of Katsuki. The heady mix of smokey incense triggered memories of how his lover's natural musk used to be. And alongside the comforting essence was the harsh, acrid smell of cigars. The smoke drifted up in thick ribbons, veiling the shadowed faces in the room with a golden haze.

Along either side of the aisle, the Yakuza sat in two unbroken lines.

Men and women poised like wolves in waiting. Their sharp eyes snapped to him the moment his foot crossed the threshold. In the middle, were the Chisakis. Kurenai's hair was down with golden charms spilling over her shoulders. On the other side of her was the stoic Takeshi. His arms were folded and his cunning eyes stared straight ahead.

And at the very center was Kai.

His gaze raised the instant Izuku appeared. That molten gold stare cut through the smoke and Izuku felt it pin him.

Kai's lips shifted into a delighted smile. He rose and languidly strode over to meet him.

"Izuku," he greeted and humbly bowed. "You look magnificent tonight in this kimono. I think the Shie Hassaikai symbol suits you well."

"I have you to thank for picking it out," Izuku acknowledged. The smallest flicker of a smile touched his lips. He maintained the mask of docility and charm. "You have great taste."

Kai stepped closer and his hand brushed lightly against Izuku's arm.

"I may have great taste, but I'm sure you'd make anything look wonderful."

The air between them pulsed with tension, and every eye in the room was assessing them closely. Izuku moved closer to the center of the room and kept his body poised.

Behind him, Tomura walked in tow, body squared out. He greeted Kai as well, along with several other higher-ups in the Yakuza. In perfect stride, he walked Kai back to his seat and took a comfortable spot amongst the others in the crowd. When he was settled, he turned to the guests and bowed, respectively.

"Thank you all for coming," Tomura began. "My lovely brother has prepared a gift for the Chisaki family tonight as a gesture of appreciation. He knows how deeply you value tradition —and intends to honor it."

Tomura leaned back and allowed his tone to deepen with intrigue. "Tonight, you'll see one of his rarest talents. Consider yourselves fortunate. Nearly everyone who has witnessed the Viridian Viper's charm paid the price in blood afterwards."

The room erupted in small laughs. Cigars glowed, and sharp teeth flashed with a sense of power.

"Izuku," Tomura called. "You can begin."

Izuku stepped into the light. It slid across his skin like liquid gold, softening the sharp lines of his face. The hum of the room fell away instantly. Every pair of eyes pulled to him as if he'd become the center of gravity.

He glanced over the crowd and stopped when he made eye contact with Chisaki Kai.

His servants were fanning him and his parents, keeping them cool as the smoke swirled up into the air.

When the music began, Izuku snapped open both of his fans. The rich gold color shimmered.

First, the strings flowed. Several simple, measured thrums echoed and wove into a labyrinthine rhythm. Then the flute followed. Soft notes slid across his skin like a wind threading through the ruins of a grave. And when the drum joined, Izuku took his first step.

He equipped himself with persuasion and moved like a serpent.

His sleeves trailed like streams of liquid as he danced. Each gesture was precise, carved into his muscles by the years of grueling discipline. The tempo swept him away as he stepped in refined, elegant expressions.

A stretch of the hand. A turn. A pivot. Then a bow.

The crowd could only stare as he spun the two golden fans with effortless command. The metal shimmered under the lanterns, scattering light across his skin until he seemed forged of twilight. With a coy dip of the wrist, he veiled his face behind one fan, only to reveal the curve of his smile as the edge traced his jawline.

He caught the deepening infatuation on Chisaki's face as he did this. It scorched the room, proving the bait was working. And right when he knew he hooked him, Izuku offered the curve of his neck in surrender.

But when he looked up again, he didn't see Chisaki.

He saw Katsuki.

Izuku's flow faltered. Quickly, he folded the stumble into a classic twirl. He carefully hid his face behind his fan. Confusion hit him like a brick, making it hard to regain balance. But when he glanced at Chisaki again, the mirage of his dead lover didn't fade—it intensified.

Fully materialized, Katsuki was sitting where Chisaki should have been.

He was in a scarlet kimono that burned as bright as a hundred sunsets. His mouth was quirked into that familiar scowl that always hid his softness. And his ash-blond hair was as wild as ever—but his skin was sun-kissed and alive.

Izuku stared as he danced. He felt a pull stronger than gravity suck him in. He moved closer to the burning, beautiful scarlet eyes. And the ghost of Katsuki watched him right back with all the love in the world.

Chills spilled down his spine when the vision leaned in with that lopsided grin.

“Dance for me, darling,” Katsuki’s phantom whispered.

The words soothed his aching heart like they were the antidote for all his pain. He continued, hiding the surge of emotion with a graceful spin. And with that twist, the world shifted. The incense became wind. The ground was grass. And the room became an open sky colored in sunset.

And Katsuki began walking towards him.

When the vision came close, Izuku’s palms caressed the air like they were brushing Katsuki’s cheek. His arms floated outward, fingers moving as if he was sculpting his dead husband from memory. He traced the sharp line of a jaw. Touched the hands that used to hold him. Skimmed phantom collarbones.

Every motion was a plea: *come back to me.*

The music climbed high. The strings pulsed like a heartbeat while the flute sang a note so aching it could have been Katsuki’s breath against his ear. Izuku’s body answered in silence, swaying low with arms stretching toward the vision.

Katsuki was closer now. So close that Izuku swore he felt the warmth of his skin.

Their eyes met and Izuku let himself drown. Katsuki began to dance with him, and a handsome grin slipped across his husband’s face. Izuku smiled back and they began to orbit each other.

No push and pull. No clash. Just perfect balance, for once in their lives.

The smoke circled them, tying like a ribbon around their bodies. Katsuki spun him and Izuku grinned as they joined in step, dancing together like they used to.

The tempo quickened, and Izuku whirled swiftly. Once, twice, and then a third time. Katsuki joined, feet gliding across the wooden aisle.

As the music swelled, Izuku danced faster. And faster. Then he spun so hard he grew lightheaded. With every whip of his head, he saw Katsuki, moving in circles with him.

He was a vision: a flower with petals unfurling in the wind.

And suddenly, this was no longer just a dance.

Izuku was begging with every line of his body for Death to change its mind. He was praying for it to bend and take mercy on them. Undo what had been permanently done. Maybe if he danced beautifully enough, Death would listen. Maybe if he offered everything in his body, Katsuki would step out of this illusion and into his arms again.

His dance went off script. It wasn’t seductive anymore, but rather full of longing.

His head tipped back, throat bared. His arms curved, gathering Katsuki in his arms. Katsuki lifted his hands and cupped his face. Izuku lulled his head, leaning into the weight of calloused hands against his skin.

A small, loving kiss pressed against his forehead.

“Perfect,” Katsuki said.

Then the music descended. Izuku turned one last time, reluctant and desperate like a comet wheeling through the night sky. He made one more plea with death and let his golden fans ripple in his hands. They rose and fell in fluid waves, resembling streams of moonlit water spilling endlessly from his fingertips.

And when the final note struck, Izuku gorgeously caved to his knees.

He sank so low his forehead kissed the floor. Silence cut through the space and the room returned. The wind became smoke again and the sunset vanished.

Izuku was back in the dim room with the Yakuza, breathing in short pulls. Sweat slid down his spine. His fingers curled into emptiness. He stayed there for what felt like forever, waiting for Katsuki’s voice to come again.

But it didn’t.

“Exquisite,” Chisaki whispered.

The word slid over Izuku’s skin like oil. Gradually, he lifted his head.

His husband was gone.

Chisaki sat where he always had. His spine was straight, and his pupils were blown wide, swallowing the gold until nothing remained but black hunger. When he eventually moved, it was to tug at his collar with two fingers. His throat worked around a swallow.

He was enamored—exactly as they wanted.

The silence shattered with the soft patter of applause. It was polite at first, then swelled like rain on a roof. Compliments rippled through the room from voices dripping with adornment.

Tomura looked stunned, and slightly confused. Izuku froze, petrified when he realized his mask had dropped. He watched his brother with slight fear as Tomura’s intelligent gaze sliced into him. And for one fractured second, Izuku swore the whole world tilted.

Then his brother moved, gradual as frost, and began to clap. But he did not smile.

Izuku’s pulse stuttered. He let his eyes flicker sideways, seeking an anchor—but what he found was worse. Ochako stood among the crowd, the only one not clapping.

She stared at him intensely, eyes glassy with tears.

“I think we have a lot to talk about tomorrow,” Chisaki spoke with a tenderness worse than cruelty.

Izuku dropped his gaze before the disgust could show. All his instincts were telling him to burn this room to the ground and run barefoot into the night until the world swallowed him whole.

But he knew, even if he did that, it still wouldn’t bring Katsuki back.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku’s pulse thrummed like wings trapped in a jar.

He was walking back to his room in silence with Ochako beside him.

After the performance, everyone showered him with compliments. How graceful he was, they said. He was truly a gem, rare and beautiful. The Chisakis were impressed. And the other Yakuza members complimented Tomura on having such an accomplished brother. When no one was looking, Izuku wandered off into the halls.

He relived the way Kai assessed him in the end. It was full of avaricious desire—much more than before. Which meant only one thing: Izuku had succeeded.

Kai wanted him. For good.

Which meant Izuku was going to be married. *Again*.

Katsuki’s face struck like lightning.

That grief from earlier came back. It rattled and shook. It slammed on the windows and screamed to be let in. He bit down on the sob rising in his throat. Hold it together, he told himself. But every step he took fractured him further. Soon, all the corners he turned, he saw Katsuki.

Katsuki alive. Katsuki waiting. Katsuki with hand stretched out.

He saw their journey, their intertwined smiles, and heard all their failed promises.

He even saw what he thought would be their future wedding. There, Katsuki was waiting for him at the end of the aisle dressed in a tux. His beautiful eyes sparkled with love as he held his breath. He stared at Izuku like he was the only other star in the sky.

And then, the precious image bled into a nightmare. The figure of Chisaki overshadowed Katsuki—waiting for him at the altar.

Izuku’s stomach lurched.

His pace quickened. His heart slammed harder, too loud in his ears. It was pounding like it wanted out of his cursed body too. *Breathe*, he told himself. But it was no good. His lungs

locked tight. It was as if the silk obi around his waist constricted like a fist and crushed his ribs.

Izuku clawed at the sash. He stumbled forward, breath breaking apart in jagged gasps.

“Izuku?” Ochako’s voice was distant. “Wh-What’s wrong?”

But he couldn’t answer. He couldn’t even think. He couldn’t breathe. Izuku bolted, feet slamming the floor. His vision tunneled. His breath rasped in his ears like a saw. Ochako’s footsteps pounded after him, but he barely heard her as the world fell away.

He reached his door and tore it open, choking on the nothingness in his lungs. The room tilted and spun. He collapsed to his knees, dragging air into a chest that wouldn’t expand. Darkness edged his vision. He squeezed his eyes shut—and it was a mistake.

Katsuki was there.

All he could see were memories. But his husband was gone. Gone. Gone. *Gone*.

He was never coming back.

“No—*no*—” Izuku’s hands tugged at the silk sash.

He frantically threw off the haori and tried to rip the obi’s knot, but failed. The kimono felt alive. It transformed into a second skin, strangling him and sealing him in. Tears blurred everything as he yanked and tore, but the silk held fast.

“H-Help me,” he choked, voice breaking apart. His nails scraped at his stomach, trying to shred himself free. “Get it off—get it *off*! *Please*!”

Ochako dropped beside him. Frantically, she tried to tear the sash off, but the tight knot wouldn’t budge. When Izuku started shaking more, she cursed under her breath, spun, and snatched the scissors from the vanity. She sliced the blade down the fabric, splitting it in two. Then she tore the kimono open with all her strength.

Air crashed into Izuku’s lungs in a single violent rush.

He collapsed forward, stripping the kimono off his skin like it was eating him alive. He was sobbing so hard his body quaked. It was almost as if the sound wasn’t him, but rather a Deity of Grief, trying to tear its way out his throat.

Every ounce of mourning, terror, and anger ripped his voice chords apart.

Ochako caught him quickly. She wrapped her arms around his trembling frame, holding him tightly as he broke apart into millions of pieces.

“H-He’s really gone,” Izuku cried, words shattered into hiccups. “He’s never coming back, is he?” His head dropped against her shoulder, tears soaking her sleeve. “My Kacchan is really gone.”

He wept, harder than the day it happened. Grief had come for him again, and it would continue to in its cruel, inconsistent waves.

Ochako said nothing.

She simply held him while his world collapsed piece by piece in her arms.

ᔓᔓᔓ

When the next day came, Tomura got everything he wanted.

Izuku stared blankly at the contract in front of him. It was massive, at least a hundred pages and stamped with the crest of the Shie Hassaikai. But instead of its usual shape, it entwined with the serpent emblem of the Viper Academy. The two symbols fused together in flawless harmony.

Flanking either side of Izuku at the table was Tomura and Zen. They were all dressed in crisp black suits with silver ties. Their hands were folded in a near identical manner.

Across from them were the Chisakis, dressed in black and gold. Kurenai and Takeshi were on either side of their son. Kurenai was smiling while Takeshi held his stern, unreadable expression. Kai brimmed with excitement. He was smiling at Izuku, eyes full of life and appreciation.

And at the center of it all, a black velvet box with a twenty five carat diamond ring.

Izuku was quiet, working on keeping his mask on his face. Signature after signature signed on the dotted lines, and just like that, he was officially sold to the Yakuza Heir. Tomura glanced at him once as he signed something on page twenty. Then Zen signed right below.

They chatted, going over the legal details of their merger.

As Izuku listened, he gathered that the Vipers would become more than mere killers for hire. They would transmute into respected parts of the Shie Hassaikai machine, an integrated limb of the syndicate. This meant Tomura and Zen were no longer lowly freelancers for hire. They were powerful co-leaders of a branch in the strongest crime family in the world.

And to top it all off, Zen got a seat at The Underground Council right next to Tomura.

In exchange, the Chisakis paid nothing for assassins. No more exorbitant fees for hired kills. No more risk of competition. The Academy was absorbed whole. Any debts from the books were scrubbed clean, and all business with future clients would be funneled through the Yakuza. This officially meant the Chisakis controlled the assassins-for-hire market in one stroke of a pen.

The Vipers' and Yakuza's perfectly symbiotic relationship was now written in stone.

Zen flipped to a page and scanned his eyes across the print.

“Children?” He asked. “Not to be rude, but these two can’t reproduce with each other.”

“Well of course not,” Takeshi replied with a snark. “We have a protocol for this type of instance. In the chance that a Heir happens to be more fond of the same sex, we have approved surrogates. They have all been screened for genetics, IQ levels, and physical beauty has also been assessed.”

“How many kids do you want to have, sweetie?” Kurenai asked.

“I think five is a good number,” Kai replied. He smiled at Izuku and cocked his head. “Izuku, how does that sound?”

He stared, sick to his stomach. He knew why Kai chose that number.

“Five sounds good,” Izuku agreed.

Kai smiled, fully sadistic.

“Five it is,” Takeshi cut in. He wrote down the number in a blank space on page fifty two. “We’ll use one surrogate, so all the kids will share DNA. The first three will be sired by Kai and the last two will be sired by Izuku. This way the first few in line will be of the Chisaki blood line.”

“Izuku does well with children,” Tomura added. He nodded towards Izuku confidently. “He’ll enjoy being a parent.”

“Oh, of course he will,” Kurenai laughed as she smiled sweetly at Izuku. “I was delighted to hear what you did for those kids, Izuku. I think that type of fiery protection is perfect for a Yakuza spouse. When I heard that, I knew you would be a *wonderful* addition to our family. You would never let anything ever happen to your children.”

“I wouldn’t,” Izuku replied earnestly. “I think children should be protected, at all costs.”

And there it was: their cycle, repeating itself without fail.

Izuku watched as more signatures bloomed across the page as they went over every minor detail. And as they did this, Izuku saw his alleged new name staring back at him: Chisaki Izuku.

It was insulting.

He ached as he reflected on how many surnames he’d gone through. He was born a Midoriya, but meant to be Shigaraki. He was then branded a Mamushi, and now he was being forced to become a Chisaki.

But he knew what he was, really. He was a Bakugou, like his dead husband. And Bakugous were spiteful. That spite had been passed down from Mitsuki to Katsuki—and now, from Katsuki to him.

And Izuku was going to wield it exactly like The Scarlet Eyed Killer would’ve.

“For the wedding, I would really love it if we invited all of our families,” Izuku suddenly added. He sweetly peered at Kai and tried his best to sell it as his fury boiled. “A big wedding has always been a dream of mine.”

“I wouldn’t have guessed that,” Kai replied with a tinge of surprise. “You seem like the type who would have preferred a smaller sized event.”

Izuku shook his head lightly, voice calm and warm.

“No,” he said, reassuring. “I think for a union like ours, all the Yakuza and Vipers should be there to witness it. It’s the joining of our families after several generations of collaboration. We should make it very lavish and celebratory.”

“I can agree with that,” Takeshi agreed, thoughtful. “But that means a lot of planning. For something that scale, we’re looking at spring, potentially even summer. We’ll need months to prepare—”

“—No.”

The word cut sharper than Izuku intended. All eyes turned to him, their surprise heavy in the silence. His pulse stuttered, but he forced a sweet smile across his lips.

“I-I mean…” He laughed gently, feigning timidity. “Waiting that long would feel like torture, wouldn’t it?” His eyes flickered toward the windows, where snow laced the night in white. “And I also think a winter wedding could be truly beautiful. It’s unique.”

Kai arched his brow with intrigue. “Eager to be by my side, are you?”

“I am,” Izuku answered smoothly. “The thought of waiting months—it seems unbearable, especially after so long of us dancing around each other.” He tilted his head, smiling tightly but convincing. “Maybe we could make it happen in two weeks?”

Kai’s eyes drifted down.

His greedy gaze lingered on the dip of Izuku’s collarbones. He inhaled deeply, and his composure tightened with restraint.

“Agreed,” he said at last, nearly breathless. He turned to his parents, and his voice shifted into a command. “Spare no expense and arrange everything immediately. Make sure this wedding is the top priority.”

They exchanged a couple of looks, but no one objected. Everyone agreed, and soon a lightness of celebration rested across the table. Zen and Takeshi began chatting like old friends and soon the conversation poured into nothing more than pats on the back and official signings.

When they reached the last page, Izuku was finally required to sign.

“And now if you put your signature here, we’re all set to go,” Kurenai sweetly told him. She handed over the pen, her golden nails shining in the light. “We’re going to have ourselves a

beautiful, big wedding!"

Izuku smiled, hiding his pain.

He looked down. His signature was required directly underneath the words *'asset purchased.'*

He signed the dotted line and sealed all of their fates.

ᔓᔓᔓ

"I can't believe we did it!" Zen cheered loudly.

He chuckled deeply from the back of his throat as he clinked his glass of whiskey with Tomura's.

"We're officially on top of the whole Tokyo Underground." He tipped his head to Tomura. "And it's all because of you."

Tomura lowered his head humbly. "I was merely doing what I know you would have done."

"And look how wonderfully it worked out," Zen chuckled.

Izuku observed, feeling like he was a world away. Zen's body language was telling him he didn't belong in this room celebrating with them, but he wasn't allowed to leave. So he kept his head down, gazing with hidden distaste at the new diamond ring on his hand. It glittered under the chandelier in the library, and it made Izuku deeply ill to be wearing it.

"To family," Zen said, brimming with triumph. "And to the future this alliance promises."

Tomura mirrored the gesture and a faint smirk tugged on his scarred lips.

"To family," he echoed.

His tone was smooth, but Izuku heard the small strain underneath it. It was a subtle reach for approval. Zen clapped him on the back. The hearty, solid strike nearly toppled the glass in Tomura's hand.

"You are great." Zen's grin widened, teeth flashing. "You're brilliant, ruthless, and *decisive*. You're exactly what I hoped Vipers would be when I started this Academy. You have just kept amazing me every step of the way. And now, you've secured my legacy."

Izuku sat to the side, smiling as neat as origami. His glass was half-lifted, fingers steady despite the quiet storm in his chest.

Zen didn't look at him. Not once. He treated Izuku as if he was another painting on the wall.

The toast continued on. Zen's booming cheer segued into some story about when he was a boy killing for Chisaki Kai's grandfather. He painted his stories in fierce, prideful strides with his booming bellow. And the whole time, Tomura subtly smiled.

As the two bonded further, Izuku tilted his glass and let the whiskey burn its way down his throat. He stared at his reflection in the amber depths for a long moment.

Another toast. Another round.

Zen poured with a generous hand, crystal singing as it filled. Izuku drank without protest. Sip after sip, the weight in his chest grew heavier.

Tomura leaned back in his chair, eyes relaxed for once. His smirk was fully satisfied. Although Izuku wondered if it was indeed satisfaction or simply the echo of Zen's praise warming his old wounds. He could see it in the way Tomura's shoulders loosened with every approving word he received.

Izuku's smile started to fade the longer he went on being ignored. He let the fire kiss his throat again and again, until the edges of the room blurred.

Zen rose at last, the picture of true power and satisfaction. His tailored coat swept the floor as he reached for Tomura once more. A final pat to his shoulder that was firm and stable.

"You've outdone yourself, Tomura," Zen repeated, voice thick with delight. "Truly, you've made me proud. Make sure you take a day off to celebrate your accomplishment."

Tomura inclined his head with the faintest tilt. He tried to play it cool, but Izuku saw the spark of validation in his eyes.

Zen barely glanced Izuku's way as he turned for the door.

"Enjoy the night, boys," he said over his shoulder, voice already fading down the corridor.

The silence left in his wake was heavier than all the whiskey in the room.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Eventually, Izuku excused himself, leaving Tomura alone to continue celebrating. Or go home. Frankly, Izuku didn't care.

He gathered Ochako and drifted into the living room that held the only TV in the estate. But really, it wasn't a living room. Not in any meaningful sense anyways because no one here ever used it. The Chisakis possessed endless luxuries at their fingertips—what was a TV compared to their lives that were already scripted like crime dramas?

But still, in true Chisaki fashion, they wanted the option.

Greed always demanded choices.

Izuku sank onto the stiff leather couch, the cold cushions pressed into him. Beside him, Ochako reached for the remote and flipped on a random sitcom. Instantly, the laugh track erupted. It was bright and slightly artificial. The sound bounced against the walls, but none of it touched him. The humor skidded off his skin like rain on glass.

Izuku's grief officially built an armor. Nothing could get in now.

He slid off the diamond ring and carelessly threw it on the coffee table.

Within a few minutes, Izuku heard his brother's footsteps approaching. Then, like clockwork, Tomura's large figure appeared in the doorway. A long, dark shadow stretched into the room and loomed. Both sets of eyes in the room wearily glanced up to see him standing there with his coat in hand.

"Uraraka." Tomura's voice cut clean through the canned laughter. "You're dismissed for the night."

She hesitated, looking between them. Uncertainty flickered in her eyes.

"Are you sure?" She asked.

"I'm positive."

Tomura's tone left no room for debate. He waited by the door, holding it open.

Ochako lingered for one last glance. Izuku gave her a small nod of reassurance that he'd be fine. She pressed her lips together, then slipped out into the hall. The door closed behind her with a click and the air in the room thickened to the point it turned stale.

Izuku kept his gaze on the TV, pretending his brother wasn't there. He didn't have the strength to indulge Tomura tonight. But Tomura, as always, didn't need permission. He strolled around like he was inspecting a cage before lowering himself next to Izuku on the couch.

His pointer finger drifted across the coffee table, tracing a neat line through the dust right next to the expensive diamond ring.

"Surprisingly filthy in here," he murmured, rubbing the gray smudge between his fingers.

Izuku glanced at him briefly. "Why didn't you head out with One? There's not exactly much to do around here."

Tomura shrugged. "It's quiet without you back home."

Izuku frowned. "What do you mean?"

Tomura pressed his lips into a thin line. He looked at Izuku and an emotion flickered in his eyes. His gaze then slid to the TV, observing the fake laughter play out on the screen.

"I'm adjusting to not having you around," he admitted. His tone was strangely fragile for him. "The dogs are sad without you. They sit outside your room, waiting for treats like you never left." He exhaled through his nose. "But I suppose once you're married to Chisaki, you'll move here. I'll just have to get used to it, even though it'll be hard."

Izuku stiffened. "Why would that be hard for you?"

“We’ve never lived apart,” Tomura replied, matter-of-fact, as if stating a law of nature. “It’s been…odd, being alone. But this is for the better. How I feel doesn’t matter.”

Izuku stared, words knotting in his throat. The weight of the confession settled: this was as close to saying *‘I miss you’* Tomura would ever come to. If this were a world before Katsuki, this small fiber of warmth would have meant everything. He would have reached for it, cherished it, and probably let Tomura manipulate him with it.

But that world no longer existed—and Tomura was the one to kill it.

Izuku turned away to keep from showing his hurt.

He looked towards the window. Outside, snow was drifting down in perfect spirals. Snow always brought him to the memory of when Katsuki was a boy. And these days, it never stopped snowing. He could perfectly see them dancing together in the sharp winter air, spinning in the cold until their cheeks were flushed pink.

Tomura’s eyes followed his line of vision.

“Is being cramped in here making you extra depressed?” He asked.

Izuku shrugged distantly. “I guess it would be nice to go outside,” he replied dully. “Fresh air is never a bad thing.”

“If I could take you outside for a bit, you wouldn’t attempt anything troublesome, would you?”

Izuku let out a short, humorless huff. “You have nothing to worry about.” He lifted one leg and tilted it so the gold-plated anklet caught the dim light. “I couldn’t go anywhere you wouldn’t find me.”

Tomura’s expression tightened for a split second.

“I can make some arrangements,” he declared. “I’m sure Chisaki would be happy to escort you somewhere now that everything has worked out. Maybe we could all go to a park, or something of that degree.”

Izuku smiled without warmth. “That would be nice.”

The laughter from the TV bubbled again, and Tomura sharply exhaled, fully irritated.

“You can drop the act, Izuku,” he said flatly. “It’s just us.”

Izuku didn’t answer. His gaze fixed on the TV screen, its glow painting shadows across his face. He gripped his hands until his knuckles whitened, fighting the tremors in his chest and the heat pricking behind his eyes.

“You’re still upset about Bakugou,” his brother said, laced with something Izuku hated to call concern. “What can I do to make you get over it quicker?”

Slowly, Izuku turned to look at his brother.

“Get over it?” The words left him like broken glass, and confusion cracked through his composure. “You think I’ll just *get over* you *killing* him?”

The slightest spark of surprise crossed Tomura’s face right before his expression hardened back to being sharp and cold. But Izuku didn’t flinch under his glare this time. He stared his brother down, desperately searching to find a shred of understanding.

But there was nothing.

He found only emptiness where humanity should be.

“You don’t get it,” Izuku muttered. His anger thinned into astonishment. “You’ll never get it because you don’t know what it’s like to love someone, do you?”

Tomura’s jaw clicked. “Izuku. Let’s not play this game.”

Izuku leaned back, examining him.

He studied his brother’s frown, the scars on his face, and the tired bags under his eyes. He finally grasped that Tomura’s heart wasn’t frozen over, it was absolutely made of ice.

It could never thaw.

“I think I actually feel sorry for you,” Izuku said. He gazed at his brother with pity, for once. “You don’t understand love, so you’ll never understand the gravity of what you did.” More tears gathered in Izuku’s eyes. “You took someone I’ve loved my whole life away from me. I can’t get over that.”

Tomura’s frown deepened. “I was doing what needed to be done—”

“—It doesn’t matter what the reason was,” Izuku explained gently. “I-I won’t be able to forgive what you did.”

Tomura froze. He leaned back as well, as if what Izuku said was in a foreign language. And for a half of a second, Izuku thought he saw an emotion—hurt, maybe. But no, Tomura didn’t get hurt. He didn’t feel. Izuku accepted that love and empathy were concepts his brother could never grasp.

They stared at each other, two points on opposite shores.

Between them stretched an ocean of blood, and at its center, Katsuki floated facedown with the scarlet swallowing his golden hair. There was nothing left between them. And Izuku knew he could never look at Tomura the same way again.

Yet knowing that didn’t dull the ache.

Somewhere deep inside, the child who once clung to his brother screamed for comfort. He needed someone to make this nightmare all untrue. And he hated that a part of him wished it

could be his big brother.

Quickly, Izuku turned away. His tears began to fall, heavy and unstoppable. He pressed his palms into his eyes and his shoulders curled inward like broken wings.

“C-Can you please just—” Izuku’s voice broke. “Just leave me alone, Tomura.”

And his brother granted his wish.

He didn’t say goodbye, and he didn’t try to say anything or press a lecture. He stood up, hovered for a moment and grabbed his coat. He walked towards the hallway and began to leave. But not before he stopped in the door frame and looked over his shoulder.

“…I’ll make some arrangements to get you some fresh air,” Tomura said quietly.

And with that, he left Izuku there by himself.

When no one was around, Izuku pulled his real wedding ring from around his neck. He gazed longingly at the eternity rubies as the sound of happiness he would never have again echoed from the TV.

☽ ☽ ☾ ☾

The rubber mat was slick with sweat.

Katsuki dropped into a deep lunge, dragging his leg forward until his thigh burned. He hissed as he tried his best to rehabilitate his body. His muscles were shuddering like they could snap at any moment. But he pushed through the pain with the mere thought of getting Izuku back.

He’d spent the last two weeks rebuilding himself from the ground up.

He pushed his body and did every single physical therapy exercise he could think of. If he wasn’t gathering his strength through resting and eating, he was holed up in the training room downstairs. He was keeping sharp by throwing punches and kicks, trying to beat the tremble out of his scratched up knuckles.

But also in the last two weeks, there was no word about Izuku.

And the silence was eating him alive.

His breath came sharp through gritted teeth. He kicked up his leg with a loud grunt, forcing his speed. He held his knee to his chest. The veins in his arms bulged as he pulled, pulled until his hamstrings screamed.

He collapsed with a heavy thud against the mat. The sound cracked through the empty lounge.

His legs were still recovering.

“Damn it,” he snarled angrily.

He slammed a fist against the floor in defeat. He hung his head low as he panted harshly. His eyes slowly drifted to the emerald ring on his finger. It gleamed in the light, encouraging him. He tried to refocus, but all he could see was Izuku's heartbroken expression from when he learned about the stupid damn deal.

Katsuki hung his head lower.

The second I find you, he promised silently. *I need to tell you how sorry I am.*

He sucked in a breath and started again. Pain clawed at his body, but he stubbornly pushed through the burn until sweat was rolling down his spine in sheets. His lips curled in victory when he lifted his knee to his chest without a wobble.

Good. This was good.

With a final twist, he stood. He rolled his shoulders and flexed his arms. His neck cracked as he tilted it side to side. The limp was mostly gone. Not perfect—yet. But he'd get there.

Right as he was about to go another round, suddenly the door burst open.

"Katsuki!" Miruko's shouted. She stood in the doorway, chest heaving and eyes blazing. "We found him."

Katsuki froze mid-breath.

His heart skipped as the room blurred with a spike of adrenaline.

He didn't remember moving. One second he was on the mat, the next he was barreling down the hall, bare feet pounding against the tilted floor. He ran as fast as he could. His pulse roared in his ears as he burst into the ops room.

He looked up frantically at the large screen—and there he was.

Izuku.

A little green dot pulsing on the map, faint but unmistakable.

Denki's hands clicked across the keyboard in a vigorous sequence. He pulled up the local CCTV footage, and the screen flickered through dozens of static images. Then it froze on an picture that drove a knife through Katsuki's chest.

It was Izuku, standing in a park beside Chisaki and a bunch of others. He was surrounded by elegant silk banners and tables that were heavy with what looked like wrapped gifts. He was poised in all black traditional winter garbs, as was everyone there.

Suddenly the static picture moved and turned into real time feed.

Izuku blinked, smiled, and bowed respectfully to someone.

Katsuki walked forward, using all the strength not to collapse in relief.

“He’s alive,” Monoma whispered, astonished.

Katsuki’s hands trembled. Shinsou patted his shoulder, trying to help share the load, but the longer Katsuki stared at the video, the more perplexed he became. There was a long line of people giving gifts and money.

Izuku awkwardly smiled at some woman with jet-black hair. Then Katsuki frowned at how uncomfortable Izuku seemed when she touched his cheek.

“What the hell are they doing?” Katsuki asked.

Miruko and Aizawa exchanged glances. They both looked at the young men in the room uneasily.

Aizawa hesitated for a moment. “It’s a Yuinou.”

Sero frowned. “What’s that?”

Miruko cleared her throat. “An engagement ceremony.”

The air in the room thickened, and Katsuki couldn’t breathe. His eyes burned into the footage they were looking at. A horrible, sinking feeling was building.

Right as his breathing began to grow uneven, another ping came from Denki’s computers. Quickly, Denki rolled his chair over to the third computer. He rapidly clicked on the alert, and a new window popped open.

“Oh shit,” Denki gasped. He turned, swallowing hard. “So. One of the Shie Hassaikai guys didn’t have two-factor authentication on his phone. I’d gotten into his email and was monitoring it to see if anything could come up, and a new message just came in…”

Denki trailed off.

“*And*?” Monoma pressed testily. “What did you find?”

“It’ll be better if I show you,” Denki suggested.

The second projector flickered on, painting the wall with an image that made Katsuki’s stomach drop.

It was a wedding invitation, printed in black and gold. Elegant ink skated across the page like it was the event of the century, and at the top were Izuku and Chisaki Kai’s names.

Lying in the center was a save the date for exactly two weeks from now.

Denki whispered as he pulled up another file. “It looks like it’ll be in this underground place called Hadeus? The wedding will be on the lowest level, hailed The Grand Hall. It’s a private space for the Shie Hassaikai.”

“Well. It looks like we got our extraction date and place,” Aizawa hissed. He ripped his scarf off his shoulders and began moving. “I’m calling Nana and letting her know right now. Everyone, begin to make preparations for fourteen days’ time.”

Miruko was right behind him. “Kaminari, start making a virtualized layout of that place.”

Everyone began shifting and prepping. But Katsuki didn’t move. He couldn’t. As everyone around him started to gather supplies, his feet were nailed to the floor.

Izuku was staring at him, smiling. But something wasn’t right.

Katsuki cocked his head at the screen. Izuku’s eyes were bloodshot, and the smile on his lips was painfully fake. But it wasn’t a typical type of fake. It was *off*. Katsuki had seen Izuku pretend smile with Koizumi and Peter Moore—and this was definitely not that.

This was destructive.

Through the footage, Chisaki wrapped an arm around Izuku’s waist. And like a match being thrown into a lake of kerosine, Katsuki’s rage roared to life. His hands curled into fists so tight the wounds on his knuckles tore again, and blood seeped through the bandages.

“I’m coming, Izuku,” he hissed. “Just hang in there.”

☽ ☽ ᔓ ☾ ☾

Izuku quietly looked at the wedding invitation.

It was on parchment paper and printed in neat calligraphy. It was perfect. Exactly how he pictured his wedding invitations with Katsuki were going to be. Slowly, the ink on the page faded, and in Chisaki Kai’s place, Izuku saw Bakugou Katsuki written instead.

Unable to look any longer, Izuku put it down.

“Well, at least on the bright side, we’ll be here together now,” Ochako said from beside him. “It’s been nice having you around here, despite everything.”

Izuku returned her smile, letting it suggest agreement. But behind it, he understood with absolute clarity that when everything finally went up in flames, she could not be anywhere near.

The next two weeks blurred together for Izuku. Time passed in strange colors—flashes of laughter in blue, clinking glasses in green, and the soft lavender hum of low conversations that never seemed to include him.

Izuku sat with Zen and Tomura in the garden one afternoon. The winter sunlight bled pale orange across stone paths. The Chisakis lingered nearby, all talking. Kai’s hands were folded neatly behind his back, eyes warm with approval and eagerness.

When Zen and Tomura were pulled into a light conversation with Kurenai and Takeshi, Kai leaned down and whispered into his ear.

“I finally got you,” he said with amusement. “I’m looking forward to our wedding night very much.”

Izuku smiled back.

“I am too,” he said honestly.

After that evening came the meetings. Days of them.

The long table in the grand hall slowly became buried under swatches of cloth. Velvets, silk, cashmere. Soon the taste testing for the dinner menu was pushed through like it was a marathon. Every servant in the estate was worked to the bone to meet the two week deadline. Hundreds of invitations were stacking up to the sky as they finalized the guest list.

And the entire time, Chisaki Kai controlled the planning.

He chose the decor, the music, and even picked out special dance performances. His deep voice commanded the room, and every word he spoke came with an iron seal.

“The music has to be classical strings,” he said. “It needs to be as beautiful as Izuku.”

“The table decor? Black and viridian roses that are as close to Izuku’s eyes as you can get.”

“We’ll also need to make sure everything has a gold accent for my family’s colors. But I would also like to make sure there are deep emerald drapes. I want it to look like a nice blend of Izuku and I.”

Piece by piece, Chisaki crafted their wedding to be everything *he* ever dreamed of. Every detail filled his vision: an event that would look less like a marriage and more like a coronation. And Izuku, drowning in his grief, sat with a smile fixed so tight it burned.

The days continued to pass, but the weight in his heart didn’t. Every choice stripped something from him until all that remained was a name he didn’t want and a ring that glared like a shackle on his finger.

It wasn’t until two days before the wedding, Chisaki seemed to realize he was there.

He rested a hand on Izuku’s shoulder.

“I almost forgot about the cake,” he said with generosity. “I think you should pick the flavor. It can be anything you want.”

ᔓᔓᔓ

Later, the kitchen was alive with heat and sweat. He walked in with Ochako into the symphony of the clatter of knives and the rhythmic scrape of sugar against metal bowls.

Izuku leaned against the marble counter with his sleeves rolled up. Thoughtfully, he watched the hundreds of chefs move like a well-oiled machine. He scanned the room, trying to find an opening that would work for his plan.

Ochako looked on too, bright-eyed as she scribbled notes on her clipboard.

It pained Izuku to think how pure she was in all of this.

After a while, a large man with round cheeks and a jovial grin approached them. The crisp white hat on top of his head marked him as the head chef. He bowed before Izuku before speaking.

“Do you have any flavors you prefer, sir?” He asked. “We need to make the batter tonight for a cake this size. We’ll be cooking it tomorrow evening.”

Izuku pursed his lips. He glanced around and his fingers tapped once against the counter. He turned to Ochako.

“What’s your least favorite cake flavor?” Izuku asked.

“Huh?” Ochako stared at him, confused. “Why does that matter?”

“I’m curious, that’s all,” Izuku replied easily. “I don’t have much of an idea, so I’m narrowing it down.”

Ochako gave it some thought. She hummed, tilted her head and tapped her finger on her chin.

“Hmm, okay. Probably matcha then,” she answered with an embarrassed chuckle. “I know a lot of people love it, but I don’t. It’s just so bitter to me, I never eat it.”

Izuku’s lips curved faintly. “Okay.”

No more than a few seconds later, Ochako politely excused herself to the bathroom. She sat her clipboard down and disappeared down the hall in a small hurry. Izuku waited until the sound of her footsteps disappeared completely. He turned to the head chef.

“Make the cake matcha flavored,” he said firmly.

ɯɯɯ

That same night, Izuku stayed awake until he heard the estate ease into silence.

The lights went out one by one, servants went home, and the Chisakis retired to their separate private wings. Izuku’s eyes were wide open in the dark, fully adjusted. For a long moment, he lay still, listening for any sounds. He heard the soft ticking of the clock. The distant crunch of snow settling on the roof outside.

But more importantly, he heard the murmur of guards outside his door. Two, to be exact.

Slowly, he pushed himself up. The sheets slid against his skin as he moved, and he swung his feet off the bed soundlessly. His bare soles pressed into the cold floor as he rose and turned on all his stealth instincts. He crouched down low, holding his breath as he reached for the hidden items under his bed.

The jar was more than halfway full now, officially gathered over a month and several days.

He eyed the collection of smuggled chemicals under the moonlight. Exhaling quietly, he steadied himself the best he could. His fingers wrapped around the emulsifier first. Then the acid. Then finally, the DMSO.

One by one, he gently mixed them into the jar of venom.

Drop by drop and swirl by swirl, the toxin slowly transformed.

The liquid gradually glowed an unnatural green, as bright as a serpent's eye.

After completing his forbidden alchemy, he set the jar down and tip-toed to the double doors. He pressed his eye to the narrow crack. In front were two guards who were rigid and alert.

Izuku soundlessly drew back and glanced at the window. Beyond the frosted glass below was the courtyard garden, the same place Ochako loved to sit and read her books.

Working quickly, Izuku stripped the sheets from the bed and twisted them into a tight braid. His fingers moved with trained accuracy, knotting fabric until it became a long rope. He anchored it to the heavy bed frame, tested the hold once, then silently pushed open the window.

Cold air rushed in. It bit his skin as if it was warning him to turn back and think about what he was about to do.

Izuku gritted his teeth and grabbed the venom. He tucked the jar snugly under his arm and gripped the rope. He pushed all the clashing thoughts in his head to the side as he slid over the ledge, and descended. The entire way down, Izuku thought of Katsuki. He kept himself seeped in the memory of his husband to make sure his perspective never wavered. The sheets swayed with his weight, but his movements were expertly fluid.

When his bare feet touched the snow, he instantly moved. He crept inside the first floor, leaving behind a small puddle of wetness behind him.

Then suddenly, he heard footsteps.

There were three guards passing on patrol on the first floor.

With no hesitation, Izuku melted into the shadows. He pressed against the wall as they walked by, deadly green eyes glowing with lethal intent. The Yakuza guards sauntered ignorantly, laughing.

"Man, I'm so relieved we're getting back all our vacation days," One guard said.

“I know, right?” Another chuckled. “Finally. I thought we’d never catch a break.”

The moment the coast was clear, Izuku moved fast. He slipped like a vengeful ghost through the halls, avoiding the pools of lamplight. He timed his steps with the creak of the old walls so his presence vanished beneath the sound.

When he finally reached his destination, his heart rate kicked up.

The kitchen doors pushed open without a sound.

Inside, warmth hit him like a comforting exhale. The faint scent of sugar lingered in the air, yet somehow all the counters were spotless. The staff cleaned up well, hiding the chaos of the cooking frenzies that’d happened. Izuku wandered a bit, ignoring the ticking of the clock in the room. It wasn’t until he got to the fourth refrigerator that he found what he was looking for.

Inside sat a massive bowl of cake batter.

The pale green shone under the moonlight.

Izuku sat the jar down. His reflection peered back at him on the venom’s surface. There was a new wrinkle on his face, and the shadows under his eyes were deeper. He’d aged nearly years —in less than two months. When did that happen?

Between the two items, his mind started to play cruel tricks again.

He half expected Hiryu’s ghost to appear and knock some sense into him. But he saw nothing. It was only him, and he couldn’t seem to shake the sudden onslaught of memories. And the longer he looked at the venom, the more he felt a pain in his heart for Tomura.

And he hated himself for it.

“You’re scared,” a familiar rasp whispered. “It’s okay.”

Izuku turned. His hands went ice-cold.

Standing in front of him was the vision of Katsuki. But unlike last time, he wasn’t lively. He looked like all the other ghosts now—dead. Blood matted his hair and face, and his clothes were saturated red. Dirt from the grave clung to him, and the rims of his eyes were raw from crying.

And at his center was the bloodied gunshot where Tomura shot him.

Izuku tried to piece together what this was. He always saw ghosts. He saw people as they were in their final moments. It was evidence of his guilty conscience. But the ghosts never spoke. They never morphed into visuals that could actually reach him—only Hiryu’s did that. So he tried to reason with his broken psyche: if Hiryu’s ghost was his instinct to survive, then what was Katsuki’s?

Only one, grim answer came to mind.

“You can do this,” the ghost encouraged sweetly. “Once it’s over, we can be together again.”

The phantom approached, and Izuku blinked away tears.

With the help of the ghost, Izuku poured the poison into the cake batter. It slipped down, making a bright green ribbon. He reached for the scoop of sugar nearby and added it generously. The grains twinkled like fading stars as they fell, steadily consumed into the thick mixture.

Then, painstakingly slow, Izuku stirred.

He folded death into sweetness until the two blended flawlessly.

And when he was done, Izuku stepped back and stared at the bowl.

There was no going back now.



The next morning, morning light spilled across the dining table for breakfast. The smell of freshly brewed coffee hung in the air, mingling with the steam rising from their food.

Izuku sat across from Chisaki. He kept his posture perfect and his hands folded neatly around a cup that had long gone cold. The shadows under his eyes were deeper, and he failed to hide his lack of sleep with makeup.

Chisaki, however, was alive with cheer. He hummed under his breath, flipping through the dinner plans and finalizing the menu. Every so often, he’d mutter something approving to himself. He’d tap the menu with a pale finger and nod, fully self-indulgent.

“Yes. Perfect,” he said. “This will be the best wedding this family has ever seen.”

Behind him, Ochako stood among the servants against the walls like protocol. Her brown eyes tracked everything and her forced smile remained in place.

Suddenly, the doors burst open with sudden brightness. Everyone’s head snapped to the entrance and in strolled the head chef. His cheeks were flushed from the kitchen’s heat and he flashed a large grin that was dripping pride.

Everyone craned their necks when from behind him, two assistants appeared.

They wheeled in a towering creation on a silver cart.

The room instantly became awe-struck. The cake was nothing short of a marvel. It was huge, five perfect tiers cloaked in deep velvety green that shimmered like gems. Pale gold scrollwork laced the sides like delicate vines, and jade-colored dust shimmered faintly under the light. And crowning it all were two viridian roses.

The chef clapped his hands together with satisfaction.

“Here it is!” he announced, voice booming with triumph. “One beautiful matcha cake!”

Everyone began to hum in delight and Chisaki Kai immediately gave his compliments. Other servants nodded happily at the glorious cake, and the two assistant chefs high-fived between themselves for their hard work.

However, while everyone else was distracted, Izuku and Ochako’s eyes met.

“It’s…matcha?” She asked, unsure.

But no one heard her besides Izuku. Guilt came in quickly and Izuku couldn’t look at her. His throat tightened as he swallowed. He kept his gaze on the table, trying his best not to crack under the heaviness in his chest. His fingers curled until his nails bit into his palm.

However, as he kept his eyes down, he missed the way Ochako glanced at him.

She frowned, tried to decode what was happening, and eyed Izuku uneasily.

Chapter End Notes

Lemme know what you think! Things are officially coming to a full peak 🥳 Next chapter is the *big* day :^D

Also super sorry for being so behind in responding to comments, I got super sick 🥹 I'm finally recovering after a long NyQuil coma but I have read and loved each and everyone one of your comments!! I smile with my coffee every morning reading every word ^^

Thank you all so much for reading <3

Chapter 46: Martellato

Chapter Summary

> Martellato (Stylistic Indication) — To play part of a piece with strong emphasis, as if hitting with a hammer.

Chapter Notes

> Hello everyone!!
>
> :D I hope you enjoyed your weekends! I am coming with an early chapter because both Luna and I are excited about this and the next. :) Thank you so much for everyone's comments! I love reading all the reactions ❤️ I hope you enjoy this one as well!
>
> **Warnings: Graphic violence**

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 46 — Martellato

.

.

.

"Matcha was a wonderful choice!"

"I love the look of it. The flowers are an amazing touch."

"Damn. This is one of the most beautiful cakes I've ever seen."

Compliments on top of compliments piled high as the kitchen staff circled the towering confection.

Izuku and Chisaki were standing next to it, quietly agreeing. His soon-to-be husband lounged with casual poise, hands tucked into his suit pockets. His golden eyes swept the cake with cool detachment. He tilted his head, and a smile tugged at his lips.

"I'm glad I left the cake to you," he said cooly, cutting his eyes at Izuku. "Matcha was an excellent touch. It fits perfectly with the color scheme."

Izuku smiled thinly. “That was the goal.”

Chisaki patted his shoulder lightly and then began chatting with the head chef. They talked about logistics, and Izuku tuned out. He turned his head, searching for Ochako. But the longer he looked, he found she was not among the crowd.

A nervous twist settled in his stomach.

He shot a quick glance over his shoulder—no one was watching him. Quietly, he slipped away. He knew the cake flavor would be strange to her. He needed to get the situation under control and make it seem like it was just him being an oddball.

As he searched for her, he began rehearsing excuses in his head. He could tell her he hadn’t thought of another flavor. Or that matcha fits the theme, like Chisaki said. However, after he thought of all the excuses in the world, he still couldn’t find her.

The next servant he saw, he tapped on the shoulder.

The short man turned to him, bowed nervously, and quietly folded his hands.

“Is there anything I can help you with, Mr. Mamushi?” The servant asked.

“Yes,” Izuku said. “Do you know where Uraraka went?”

The servant blinked, surprised. “Oh. She left after the cake was revealed. She said there was an emergency with her family.”

Izuku froze.

She left? Just like that?

“My apologies, sir,” the man added quickly. “I thought she said she told you. Shall I send someone to retrieve her—”

“—No,” Izuku interrupted. “It’s fine. You’re right, she did mention it. Leave her be, please. I don’t want to disturb her family.”

“Are you sure? It really is no problem.”

“Yes, I’m very sure. Sorry for bothering you.”

Izuku promptly excused himself, leaving the baffled man behind. Thousands of thoughts began to race because something about Ochako’s sudden departure was wrong.

Rather than heading back downstairs, Izuku walked to his room. Once he was inside, his sharp eyes slid side to side. He examined the dresser, the vanity, and then double-checked the snake cage.

However, he found nothing. It all looked ordinary. Exactly how he left it.

Nevertheless, his gut was twisting.

He dropped to his knees and checked beneath the bed.

Immediately, his heart plummeted through the ground.

Sitting underneath his bed was his hidden notebook. It was covered underneath a sweater, completely non suspicious to any eye. He'd given the house cleaners orders not to touch his room, and they always respected his word.

However, Ochako sometimes still cleaned, out of kindness.

And now, his notebook looked touched. It was exactly an inch out of place from where he left it. And on top of that, the sweater he placed over it was crumbled entirely differently.

Izuku slowly rose to his knees, notebook in hand.

He swallowed and his nerves spiked.

ᔓᔓᔓ

The next morning approached, and Ochako called in. She informed everyone she was going to be late.

Chisaki asked Izuku if he wanted guards to retrieve her, but Izuku declined. In her place, another servant filled in. The man's name was Mr. Noboru. He was an older gentleman whose eyes were as calm as the ocean.

He'd been paying off a debt to the Chisakis all his natural life.

Mr. Noboru helped him prepare for the wedding. Together with the Chisakis, they reviewed the last details. The coordinated dances. The menu. The order of events and speeches. Izuku watched it all, absorbing the details, so he knew exactly how the last few moments of his life would go.

"Once the cake is cut, you'll move right into your first dance," Mr. Noboru explained. "After that, the floor will be open for everyone to join in."

Izuku nodded. He did the calculations. Since it was being ingested, the venom would spread slowly. First would come the stomach pains. Then, the acid would take over. It would gnaw through the gut lining and allow the venom to spill into the blood stream.

And from there, the shutdown would begin. Organ by organ.

Which meant that by midnight, the poison would claim anyone who ate a piece of the cake.

To quiet the unease curling through his chest, he returned to the choreography again and again. He lost himself to rehearsing the steps until his body moved entirely on muscle memory.

As he did this, he waited for Ochako to return.

He waited through the morning.

Then again into the afternoon.

However, by evening, he understood she wasn't coming back.

She'd seen his notebook. She must have. Had she pieced together the scribbles and the cake? Was she planning to tell the Chisakis? He braced himself for everything to collapse—yet nothing happened.

Maybe she simply ran. And though dread lingered, Izuku was content with that.

The further away she was, the safer she would be.

ᔓᔓᔓ

The rehearsal dinner lingered long into the evening.

The Chisakis and all their kin filled every seat at the table. Aunts, uncles, and cousins from all over flew in for the wedding. They raised their glasses to Kai again and again, congratulating him on his acquisition. Their voices boomed with pride, celebrating Kai for yet another successful merger. He truly earned the name Overhaul, his father said boastfully.

Izuku sat through it all, right next to his future husband.

His smile stayed fixed in place, while beneath the table the metal anklet dug against his skin.

When the last toast was given, the family rose to their feet. They put on their coats and scarves with bright smiles, voices spilling down the corridors like a powerful tide. They congratulated Kai one more time at the door, laughing loudly, eager to continue the night with drink and spectacle.

"C'mon!" One of the uncles barked, beckoning with a meaty hand. "Tomura! Zen! Come with us. We're going out on the town in Tokyo, and you'll both drink at our table tonight!"

Instantly, a grin split across Zen's face. He rose to his feet with the heat of sake already red in his cheeks.

"Of course!" He said, laughing so loud it rattled the silverware.

He grabbed his coat and followed the crowd out. But Tomura didn't move. He stood still and neatly folded his tattooed hands into his pants pockets. When Zen saw Tomura wasn't right behind him, he paused with one foot out the door.

He turned, confused. "You're not coming?"

Tomura shook his head. "I'll celebrate here, with him."

His chin tilted toward Izuku, who was still seated at the table.

Zen hesitated, the laughter clinging to his throat like surely that must've been a joke. But Tomura didn't laugh, and he didn't move. His steady gaze held firm showing that he was indeed serious. When Zen realized this, he huffed. With a shrug, he raised his hand in parting.

"Suit yourself," Zen muttered, slightly disapproving.

He didn't give more as he shut the door behind him. His voice blended into the rowdy chorus of the Chisaki family and then, all together, they faded away.

The house fell silent. There weren't many guards tonight and all the servants were given the evening off in preparation for tomorrow. The large estate, for once, now seemed as hollow as Izuku felt.

He glanced down at his ankle monitor.

"So," he said, voice edged with irony. "How exactly are we supposed to celebrate?"

Tomura crossed the room without hurry, allowing his steps to echo in the emptiness. He reached underneath the seat he was at for the rehearsal dinner—and he revealed a case of shochu.

Izuku blinked in surprise.

For once, Tomura's voice was soft, almost kind. "Like this."

ᔓᔓᔓ

The elevator chimed softly, carrying them to the highest room in the estate.

It was a space seldom used, with walls made entirely of glass. Through those portals, a perfect view of Tokyo's sea of lights. The endless neon blinked below, like the steady thrum of a heartbeat in the city that never slept.

For a moment, Izuku stood there, soaking in the giant metropolis he always called home. A bright blue and purple glow washed over his face, and he started to reminisce. He recounted all the different places he'd been across the world, yet somehow he always ended back here.

Always.

Tomura moved to the small cabinet against the wall. It was adorned with different vintage vinyl records. records. He chose one without looking too hard and placed it on the track. With casual ease, he grabbed two champagne glasses from the cart off to the side.

As he poured the shochu, the space filled with soft music.

"I won't bother you with a speech," he said, handing a glass to Izuku.

The silence that followed was easily familiar. Tomura always kept his thoughts close, leaving Izuku to guess at what could be running through his head. But tonight there was no need to wonder. Tomura was relaxed, sitting on top of the world, basking in his accomplishment.

He'd finally gotten everything he wanted.

After several glasses, they drifted to the floor, legs crossed before the vast window with their shochu in hand. Tomura leaned back on one arm, gaze soft as he traced it across the radiant skyline.

"You know," he murmured, almost wistful. "I think we've been over every inch of this city."

"Yeah," Izuku agreed, eyes roaming over the buildings he knew so well. "You're right."

"There," Tomura said, pointing to a narrow street lined with low buildings. "Remember that alley? It was one of the first Viper Seven missions we were on. The mark we were chasing almost got away because Aoyama tripped and fell into the middle of traffic somehow. He nearly got flattened by a truck."

Izuku's lips quirked. That memory was fairly humorous. "Yeah. I remember. You yelled at him for hours afterwards and put him on desk duty indefinitely."

Tomura chuckled. "It was the right thing to do." His eyes sharpened as he raised his glass again. "And over there," he said, pointing off into the eastern distance. "Your favorite ice cream shop is somewhere in that heap. You always asked me to take a break there, even on the coldest nights."

"I don't remember begging that much," Izuku retorted quietly. "But, they really do have the best ice cream."

Tomura's gaze lingered on him, eyes unreadable in the half-light. Then he gestured toward the western edge of the city, where the lights flickered like dying stars.

"And there. Your first assignment. You froze at first, but you did it anyway. That's when I knew…"

His voice trailed off, lost in the music.

Izuku swallowed.

That memory was horribly bittersweet. But still, it washed over him like the neon tide beneath them. He took another sip of shochu, welcoming the warmth to mingle with the ache of what had been and what was to come.

Tomura studied him. Izuku could feel the unspoken weight beneath his brother's eyes as he stared back: every memory they shared, every laugh and painful clash was documented in invisible footprints in the city below.

They sat like that for a long while. Music soft and the glasses warm in their hands.

For once, they seemed bare: just two brothers sharing a moment.

And then dull pain shot through Izuku's heart. It was horrible, wasn't it? Tomura had been there from the beginning, somehow both his greatest torment and his only lifeline. His brother stayed true to his word and kept him alive at all costs—but oh, how steep those costs had been.

And once more came the question. The one that haunted him, the one he'd never been able to decode.

If there was ever a night to ask, it was this one.

"Tomura," Izuku murmured, voice tight. "Can I ask you something?"

"Of course," his brother replied. "You can ask anything you want the night before your wedding."

Izuku's eyes fixed on Tokyo, searching for those towers of glass where they were raised.

"…Have you ever loved me?"

Silence fell. But Tomura's face betrayed nothing.

"Is there a reason you're asking me that?" He asked, tone sliding icy.

"I need to know if you've ever really loved me," Izuku explained, twisting his hands. He stared into the rippling drink as grief pressed its weight into his features. "Some days it feels like you might. Other days…I'm not so sure."

"And today is one of those days where you're unsure?"

Izuku shrugged, unable to find his voice.

Tomura sucked his teeth and let the pause stretch. "We don't have to do this, Izuku. There's no point in dissecting our emotions."

"I need an answer, Tomura," Izuku pushed. "I-If I'm going to go through with tomorrow—I need to know."

He looked up, and met his brother's gaze. He searched there, and he saw all the versions of Tomura from youngest to now. They all looked at him, giving absolutely nothing, and it made Izuku's heart ache.

"…I don't know," Tomura whispered.

The words took a while to settle.

They drifted there, three words that were not the three his inner child wanted to hear. He stared, trying to grasp it, but the uncertainty was too thick to see through.

“You don’t know?” Izuku whispered, pained.

“No. I don’t.” Tomura shrugged, as if too tired for this. “It’s hard to know what you feel when you don’t have anything to measure it against.” He gestured out to the city of Tokyo. “Look at how we grew up, Izuku. How would I *ever* know what love feels like? We weren’t even allowed to be affectionate.”

That made sense, Izuku supposed.

He deflated, feeling silly for asking that type of question to someone who Zen deemed to be the *perfect* Viper. Of course this was the answer.

Right as Izuku was about to accept that, Tomura swayed. He leaned forward and turned his whole body to Izuku. He met him head on, and there was a shift in the air. Tomura quietly put his glass down and folded his hands.

“But I guess, if you need an answer,” Tomura said in a strangely soft way. “On most days, I know I care for you.”

“…And on the others?” Izuku pressed.

“On the other days, I resent you.” His voice was flat, factual. “But that’s part of the job.”

Tomura continued, voice shifting to something close to a reluctant tenderness.

“There’s never been a moment I didn’t have to worry about you,” he explained. “I was seven and needed to figure out what you liked to eat. I needed to make sure you did your homework and trained. I even potty trained you. I did everything while no one did anything for me. Everyone else had a Big to guide them, but I only had you—and I couldn’t even make you stop crying. And when you cried, I was punished. So I resented you. Over and over.”

“…Sorry,” Izuku said, almost automatic.

“It’s fine.” Tomura leaned back and looked at Izuku in an almost fond way. “I eventually figured out how to make you stop.”

“You did?” He asked, surprised by the turn of the convo.

“Yeah. It took me a while. But, you liked being held.” A bitter edge crept into his tone. “Honestly, you being so soft is probably my fault, in an ironic way. I coddled you when we were kids. I knew I wasn’t supposed to, but hugging you was the only way to calm you until you fell asleep. You were too young to remember this I’m sure.”

Quietly, something called from the back of Izuku’s memory.

It was covered in thick, hazy fog and subtle as a distant lullaby. He stared at Tomura, trying to grasp onto it. The longer he did, the more clear it became.

“I…I think I remember a little,” Izuku said.

Tomura raised a brow. “Really?”

“Yeah.” Izuku nodded, and the memory took shape. “I remember you letting me sleep in your bed, reassuring me that there were no monsters in the closet.” He blinked, surprised. A faint smile touched his lips. “You said they were all out in the hallway, and if I kept crying, they’d come inside and hurt us.”

Tomura scoffed dryly. “Did I lie?”

“No. I guess you didn’t.”

Tomura took another long swig, bitterness twisting his mouth. The influence of alcohol was evident in his eyes, and Izuku realized this was the first time he’s ever seen his brother close to tipsy.

“Maybe that’s why I still get the urge to coddle you whenever you cry,” Tomura muttered quietly. “That’s the one weakness I can’t seem to shake.” He scoffed sourly, and swirled his drink. “The power of familial bonds, huh? They cling to your instincts so deeply, whether you want them to or not. It’s fate, really.”

And that was something Izuku couldn’t agree on.

Fate didn’t exist to Izuku anymore, it died with Katsuki. All that he could believe in was ripples of consequences passed down from one person to another.

Tomura gave him a look, as if he knew Izuku rejected his sentiments.

Slowly, his brother raised his glass, and held it out for a toast. Izuku followed and clinked their glasses. They leveled gazes, and an unnamed energy surged between them. They both drank, lifting the glass to their lips again.

As the burn hit his throat, the memory of Tomura shooting Katsuki showed itself.

It played again and again cruelly, reminding him that the person his inner child loved was the same one his adult self hated. And that was a duality Izuku needed to accept because Tomura was bound to the cycle he was seeking to destroy. His brother carved himself into its shape so completely that he could never be anything else, even with his weakness.

And though they shared a bond, there was no reality where both their visions of the future could coexist.

Tomorrow would decide which one of them would get their wish: the one who kept the wheel turning, or the one who broke it apart.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Morning came too brightly, as if the sun itself had no sense of the weight it illuminated.

The estate stirred awake with restless movement. Doors opening. Voices rising. Izuku heard the scrape of countless chairs and the shuffle of fabric below his bedroom.

He stayed in bed as long as he could, flipping through the photos of Katsuki.

No one came for him, likely letting him rest.

And as the day dragged forward, Izuku felt a heaviness stalk him.

It was a looming sensation that crept just beyond reach, lingering in the corners of his vision. It was subtle at first, hiding where the shadows were shortest. But as the hours passed, the shadows lengthened. They stretched across the ground, crawling toward him with patient inevitability.

The light dimmed by degrees and with it came a terrible certainty: when those shadows finally touched him, it would be for the last time.

It was not a feeling he found unfamiliar. He'd walked with it all his life, stood shoulder to shoulder with its presence. In the past, he'd only witnessed it and helped it close in on someone else. But this time was different.

This time the shadow chose him.

It wasn't until it was near dusk, did someone finally come and check in on him.

"Mr. Mamushi," Noboru called gingerly with a soft knock. "It's nearly time for you to get ready. We will be coming with your montsuki in ten minutes. Is that alright?"

"Yes, that's alright," Izuku replied. "Thank you."

With all his strength, Izuku pulled himself from the bed. Dusk orange kissed his cheeks through the window, painting his crestfallen face in beautiful hues of red, yellow and gold.

He patiently watched the sunset until there was no more light.

The shadows were officially here.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku sat on the edge of his bed, waiting and fiddling with his eternity ring.

The slow creak of the door broke the silence. He looked up, expecting Mr. Noboru. However, he froze in shock when it was Ochako. She eased herself through the door, alone and carrying his wedding garments. As she clutched the robes, on her face was a pale, pain stricken expression that weighed heavy on her eyes.

"Ochako—" Izuku stumbled to his feet, surprised. "Y-You came back."

Her eyes swept over him, lingering and retreating all at once. She forced a fragile smile.

“Hi, Izuku,” she whispered. Bowing low at the waist, she struggled to lift her gaze. “I’m sorry for disappearing. It won’t happen again.”

“It’s okay,” he reassured quickly. “Is…everything alright with your family?”

He stepped closer, bracing for her to confront him about what she knew. But she kept her eyes lowered and shifted away.

“Yes. Everything is fine,” she murmured, staring at her feet. “I only wanted to spend some time with them.”

“That’s good.” He tilted his head and twisted his fingers together. “I should explain about the cake—the matcha wasn’t to upset you. I thought it fit the green theme Chisaki wanted—”

“It’s okay,” she cut in, a touch too quickly. “We don’t need to go over it.”

Izuku frowned. “Are you sure?”

Her silence answered for her.

“I brought your montsuki,” she replied instead, her voice pitched too bright as she lifted the garments. “Let’s get you ready so we can stay on schedule.”

He hesitated and wanted to press more, but Ochako slipped past him without giving any leeway.

She began laying the silk robes out in order. Izuku watched her shoulders tense with every motion, unease tipping back and forth in his stomach. Her body language screamed what her lips refused to say, but he couldn’t risk exposing more than he already had.

So he yielded.

“…Alright,” he murmured.

They dressed in silence, opposite to the usual laughter they typically shared.

First, the black and gold hakama pants, then the crisp white under-layer came next. Soon the heavy silk layers wrapped tighter and tighter around him. The cloth squeezed his chest with every tie, locking him in. There was a brief moment of hesitance before Ochako cinched the obi around his waist. She kept her touch quick and careful, and the silence between them grew.

When she was done, Izuku stood before the long mirror.

The top of the montsuki was a white so bright it looked like the purity Chisaki always fetishized. Golden threads wove in and out across the silk, forming geometric flowers that shimmered only when the light caught them. Across the back blazed the pure gold crest of The Viper Academy—his mark of belonging.

And at his ankle was the golden ankle bracelet, tracker still blinking.

Ochako moved behind him. She began raking product through his thick hair and parted it neatly down the center. With a delicate hand, she brushed color across his cheeks, tinted his lips a deeper pink and traced a faint line to sharpen his eyes.

When she stepped back, her reflection lingered beside his.

He looked perfect. Like a true Yakuza spouse.

Their eyes met in the mirror, only for her to look away almost instantly, as if the weight of his gaze was too much to bear. Izuku pressed his lips into a thin line.

There was one more thing he needed to do.

“Ochako,” he called gently, “I wanted to give you something before the wedding begins.”

She frowned, confused. “You’re giving me a gift on your wedding day? Izuku, it should be me giving you something.”

He crossed the room without answering and paused at his dresser. From its surface he picked up a small, purple velvet bag. When he turned he gave her a tender smile and walked back to press it into her hands. When she didn’t immediately take it, Izuku folded her fingers around the soft pouch.

Her voice was unsteady. “Wh-What is this?”

“The jewelry the Chisakis gave me.”

Her eyes widened. Immediately, she tried to push it back into his hands, shaking her head. But Izuku anticipated this. He closed her hands firmly around the bag, insistent.

“It won’t be missed,” he promised. “I thought…maybe you could use it for your family’s debt. The gold necklace with the large square emerald alone is worth more than enough if you pawn it. Please, Ochako. Take it. Use it to get—”

Her cry cut him off.

He nearly jumped back, and his eyes went wild. Piece by piece, she broke down. The sound ripped out of her throat before she could stop it. Izuku froze when she collapsed into tears with her shoulders shaking violently.

“—Izuku,” Ochako cried. “I’m s-so *sorry*.”

Her face fell and Izuku’s heart dropped.

Through the tears, she placed the bag of jewelry off to the side. Instead, she cradled Izuku’s hands in her own as if she was trying to shield him from the world.

“I’m sorry I couldn’t do more,” she whispered through her sobs. “I’ve been trying to help, I’ve been trying *so* hard to make things feel lighter for you, but none of it can undo the pain

they've put you through, can it? I thought I could keep doing this job, that I could stay neutral, but…"

She lifted her head and looked him in the eye.

"You're too *selfless*, Izuku. I can't stand by and pretend I don't know what you're about to do."

The fractured pieces of Izuku's heart ground against each other in his chest.

"I-I don't know what you mean," he deflected.

But she wasn't fooled.

She pushed, her eyes searched him as if she were reaching for the truth that sat against his tongue. He knew then that there was no hiding. She was as smart as he always knew, and this was the exact reason he tried to be as careful as possible around her.

"When I saw the cake," she admitted with shame laced in her words. "I thought it was some kind of cry for help. I can't explain why, but the look on your face when they showed it made me think something else was wrong. So I…I went through your room." Her voice shrank, ashamed. "I'm sorry. I know that was an invasion of your privacy, but I was worried."

She paused.

"I found your notebook."

Izuku's heart stopped.

"I thought it was a journal," she confessed brokenly. "I opened it to see if you were spiraling worse than I thought—but then I saw what you'd written inside." Her grip on his hands tightened, and she looked at him with wide, pleading eyes. "I know you're planning on poisoning yourself."

For a moment, he could only blink. Then, his face softened with a sadness too heavy to hide.

She didn't know the full scope of what he'd set in motion.

"I don't know when you're planning it, but please, *don't*," she begged, stroking his hand with shaking fingers. "The Chisakis aren't worth your life. I promise we'll figure something out. I already talked to my father—he thinks maybe, ma-maybe we can find a way to get you out. It's a long shot, but it's better than this. *Please*. Don't do this to yourself."

Her tears fell hot against his knuckles, and Izuku, almost against his will, tightened his hold on her hands.

"…Ochako."

"*Please*." Her voice filled with sobs. "Izuku, please don't. *Don't*."

His vision blurred, and he tried to hold it together. But his body betrayed him, as it always does. With a heartbreaking smile, his lips trembled with his next words.

“I’m sorry,” he rasped. “It’s too late.”

Pain struck across Ochako’s round face, making her lower her head as tears slipped free. Izuku turned away too, fighting back his own cries.

This wasn’t at all what he expected. But somehow, this was worse.

She clung to his hands stubbornly. Her tremors passed into him until they could no longer tell whose grief belonged to whom. Slightly desperate, Izuku’s gaze flickered around the room. One more time he searched for something—*anything*—else he could give her before it all went to waste.

Slowly, her crying subsided into soft sniffles.

Ochako wiped at her damp cheeks with her sleeve, and when she lifted her head, their eyes met again.

Through all the sorrow, there was an ember of light in her.

“I was worried you’d say something like that,” she said, her voice firmer now. She straightened, released his hands, and reached into her pocket. Without hesitation, she pulled out something small and pressed it into his palm. “Here.”

Izuku uncurled his fingers—and his breath caught. “Is this—”

“—the anti-venom.”

Izuku was speechless.

He stared at the vial made of amber glass, no bigger than half his palm. Its surface was marked with a simple label: ***mamushi***. A scarlet cap sealed it, holding within the remedy to all the destruction that’d manifested from his broken heart.

“I spent all of yesterday trying to find it on the black market,” Ochako explained quietly. Her hand came up to close his fingers around the vial, her touch both firm and sorrowful. “It’s a triple dosage. Strong enough that even if you take it late, you’d still have a chance. A slim one—but a chance.”

Izuku’s mind was reeling. It spun and spun, circling back to the same truth: how unbearably kind she’d been to him.

Ochako lowered her head, as if there was nothing more left for her to give. Her eyes drifted toward the clock.

“It’s almost time.” She drew in a shallow breath before asking, “Do you want me…there at the wedding?”

The double sided tone made Izuku know what she was really asking.

“No.” The word faltered in his throat. “I want you to go home and be with your family.”

Pain filled her eyes, but she nodded.

“Okay.” She reached for the nearby table, gathering what little resolve she possessed. “Then let’s fix your makeup. You cried out all your eyeliner.”



When they stepped out of the room, Izuku carried the anti-venom in his hand while Ochako clutched the velvet bag to her chest. Both of them were composed on the surface, but their silence swelled with everything said.

Together, they descended the stairs toward the foyer, where voices and footsteps stirred in restless anticipation. Just before the noise could swallow them, they stopped short. They lingered for a while in the quiet pocket between worlds.

Izuku turned to her. “Thank you. For everything.”

Ochako’s lips pulled into the gentlest smile she could muster. “And the same for you.”

She bowed low, as if pressing the farewell into the marrow of her bones. When she rose and turned away, the motion dragged with a sorrowful gravity. Much like someone retreating from the shore while the tide pulled a stranger under. She wanted to reach back and save him —but she possessed no raft to offer and no rope strong enough to pull him free.

So Izuku stayed where he was, alone in the undertow.

He looked down at the vial glinting in his palm.

She’d given him a choice that only he could decide: swim or drown.

But he knew the truth. He drowned long ago.

“Are you ready?” Tomura’s voice cut in, a little too close.

Izuku jolted, nearly dropping the vial.

He tightened his fingers around it before turning. Like an ever-present shadow, his brother stood there. He was dressed in a tailored black suit with his hair tied back with a strip of red string.

“I am,” Izuku answered quickly, forcing steadiness into his tone. “I’m just taking a moment to gather myself before the big event.”

Tomura inclined his head, accepting the excuse. “Understandable. We’ll wait here a little longer. But not too long, alright? Take a deep breath, and you’ll be fine.”

Izuku nodded, throat dry.

Tomura leaned against the wall and pulled out his phone. As he typed, Izuku's palms dampened with sweat. Carefully, he slid the vial into his pants' pocket, praying Tomura's attention stayed elsewhere. When he seemed in the clear, he exhaled and began silently counting backwards from ten.

In the lull, he studied his brother.

Tomura was dressed in the ever famous Yakuza Black Tie Attire: black suit, silver tie, and black leather shoes polished to perfection. To top it off, his twin machetes rested across his back in their usual X—the perfect mix of fashion and intimidation.

His silver rings encircled his fingers, the king cobra one was recently polished, and his piercings and tattoos caught the light in a way that made him seem more threatening than usual.

For a second, Izuku tried to commit it all to memory. This version of Tomura might be the last he ever saw.

Tomura's eyes lifted. He frowned and sighed through his nose.

"Forever the crybaby," he muttered, annoyed.

Izuku stiffened as Tomura reached out. His thumb brushed away a tear Izuku hadn't realized fell. Their gazes met, and Izuku's nerves strained under the weight of it. Suddenly, Tomura stepped forward, eyes unreadable and contemplative.

Then without warning, Tomura did something he hadn't done since Izuku was thirteen.

He hugged him.

The embrace shocked Izuku to his core. His whole body went stiff, and a roaring clash of emotions ruptured inside of him. Under the turmoil, the world fell away. He didn't feel inside the Chisaki estate anymore, but rather back home at The Viper Academy in their old room.

A vulnerability he never could shake with Tomura came running forward. It pulled him to lean in as his brother's arms cradled him closely. Izuku tried to fight it. He tried to resist. He wanted to remain angry until the bitter end. But, he couldn't.

He was only human at the end of the day.

With trembling arms, Izuku hugged his brother back and melted into the embrace. They both stayed there suspended in time for a generous minute.

How cruel, Izuku thought. His brother chose this moment, of all moments, to be the softest he's ever been.

When Tomura pulled away, he rested his eyes on Izuku's face.

He tucked the stubborn curl behind Izuku's ear.

"It's time to go, little brother."

☽ ☽ ☾ ☾

Leather gloves, tightened. Holster, snapped shut. Boots, zipped.

Katsuki loaded his third gun with a hard snap and locked it into place at his hip. The chest holster came next. He pulled it taut across his chest, the weight of knives and guns pressed against him like they were his old companions.

Without hesitation, he tossed back three high-dose painkillers.

The bathroom mirror stared back at him. He was dressed head-to-toe in black tech gear, pockets teeming with ammo, blades, and slim trackers for when their plan inevitably went to shit. Taking a large inhale, Katsuki adjusted a strap and straightened his spine.

His limp was officially gone, which meant his body mended well enough to be thrown into the fire again.

He strode through the halls of The Company's Yokohama headquarters. Every glance that landed on him caught the mean sneer etched across his mouth.

In the past two weeks, everyone dug their heels into preparing.

Shinsou sharpened his blades. Monoma drilled himself in the shooting range. Sero ran hand-to-hand combat drills with Miruko until both their knuckles bled.

And lastly, Denki buried himself in hacking. He acquired multiple stolen files through cracked accounts. He pulled everything they needed: floor plans, a wedding program, and a detailed map of the nine circles of Hadeus from Yakuza servers.

All of it funneled toward one purpose: get Izuku out, *alive*.

Katsuki pushed into Aizawa's private ops room. The air was already thick with the smell of gun oil. A large, long steel table was in the dead center, and their entire teams circled around it. Everyone was homed in, checking weapons and syncing phones.

Aizawa glanced up, and within a second took two strides towards him.

"Make sure you don't lose these," he said sternly as he placed an earpiece into Katsuki's hand followed by a signal tracker.

Katsuki nodded, snuggly fit the earpiece in place, and pinned the tracker to his holster.

"We won't stand out too much in this, will we?" Sero asked.

He flexed his gloved fingers and eyed everyone's black tactical get up.

“Where you’re going, you’ll blend in fine,” Aizawa replied. “Just remember to keep your weapons hidden. Don’t point them at Yakuza personnel until the moment is right. This is an extraction. Not a war.”

“I beg to differ,” Monoma muttered while adjusting the silencer on his pistol.

“Hey,” Miruko barked. She pointed up to the screen on the wall. “Izuku’s tracker is officially on the move.”

Everyone glanced up to see the projected map. The tiny blinking green dot was in fact moving, at a fast pace—directly towards Hadeus. Katsuki’s eyes narrowed in, struggling to look away as Izuku’s signal moved further and further into the heart of the city.

“Alright, everyone—set your watches,” Aizawa ordered. “Things are officially in motion. We’re going to review the plan one last time.”

Aizawa pressed a small clicker in his hand. The massive screen dominating the wall split into two. One side showing Izuku’s location, and the other flooded the room in a cold, blue light.

A 3D render of Hadeus appeared on the screen. It rotated slowly—showing all nine circles in their glory.

“Starting at the surface,” Aizawa said, sweeping the room with his gaze. “You all will descend with the crazy crowds. This wedding isn’t only a family affair—it’s a spectacle that’s drawing a lot of attention. People from the Tokyo underground scene will be there along with other big players from across the country. Everyone is there to show support for the Yakuza Heir securing his legacy.”

Miruko leaned forward and tapped the screen where the top circle gleamed.

“The parade kicks off in Limbo, the first circle,” she said. “It winds all the way down to the Ninth, where the ceremony and reception are locked behind guarded doors. From here, only those invited will be allowed in. The rest of the crowd will scatter back up, drinking and celebrating.”

Shinsou frowned deeply. “So every level is going to be jammed?”

“Packed shoulder-to-shoulder,” Miruko grinned, feral. “But that works in our favor. It’ll be easy to vanish in crowds like that, unlike last time.”

Aizawa pointed to the map again. “Bakugou, Sero, Shinsou, Monoma—you’re the ground team. Your job is to stay close to the parade and get eyes on Izuku. Then you’re going to find a way inside that reception.”

The map zoomed down to the Ninth circle and floor plans appeared in clean cut lines.

The ceremonial hall was perfectly laid out alongside the banquet chamber, and all the exits were marked in red.

Katsuki’s stare locked onto the glowing green marker for Izuku’s seat.

His heart pulled towards it.

Aizawa continued, “Intel from Chisaki Kai’s personal assistant’s emails says the Heir is planning to leave immediately after the reception. He has a private jet set for an unknown destination. If Izuku boards that plane—we lose him. Forever.”

Sero shifted uneasily. “Er. I’m still not sure how we’re supposed to break into the ceremony room.”

“We’ll figure it out,” Katsuki said flatly. His eyes burned holes into the seat marked for Chisaki Kai. “There’s always a way in.”

“Bakugou’s right,” Aizawa confirmed. “I trust you four to improvise. But once Izuku’s in your hands, it’s all going to go to shit. The Yakuza will come down on you hard and that’s when you all need to run like hell.”

The map expanded outward again. Two bright trails in the colors orange and green shot upward through the spiraling undercity. They weaved across multiple floors around buildings, roofs, and stairs until they broke to the surface of Tokyo.

“This is where the split happens. Team A.” Aizawa pointed to the orange line. “And Team B.” He dragged his finger to the green line.

“Team A will be Shinsou, Sero, and Monoma,” Miruko said. “You’re the decoy team. Monoma, you’ll wear the disguise. The second you have Izuku, take his clothes and bolt. Hopefully this makes the Yakuza chase you and all you need to do is lose them. Your job is to keep running until you hit the surface. I’ll be waiting at your exit with the car. We’re going straight back here to Yokohama.”

Aizawa clicked again and the screen began to follow the flow of the green line.

“Team B is going to be the real extraction,” Miruko explained. “It’ll be Izuku and Katsuki. The moment you split, strip Izuku of anything identifying. You won’t have a lot of time, but get a hoodie on him and keep his face down in the crowds.”

“Bakugou,” Aizawa said, eyes meeting him. “When you surface—I’ll be there waiting with a vehicle.”

Katsuki nodded once, sharply. He turned his eyes back on the glow green route on the screen, burning the path into memory.

“Alright!” Sero cracked his knuckles with a smile. “I think I got it. This is going to be a piece of cake.”

Monoma tsked at Sero. “This seems like a piece of cake to you?”

“Sort of,” Sero replied with a toothy grin. “It reminds me of when we went to South Korea to help rescue that gangster’s daughter. It was on a smaller scale, but very similar. I remember that being a bit of a breeze.”

“It was a breeze because you were on clean-up, not ground ops,” Monoma deadpanned.

Shinsou snorted next. “Yeah, that extraction nearly went to hell.”

“Extractions rarely go smoothly,” Aizawa added, dead serious. “But that’s why you’re all going to stay on your toes and communicate, got it?” He tapped the ear piece on the side of his head. “Make sure to give active updates and if you need help—signal.”

Denki, stationed at the tracker console, waved. “I’ll try my best to assist along the way! I’ve got eyes on everyone from here and I figured out the IPs for a lot of Yakuza devices. If anything goes sideways, I’ll guide you or reroute you—whatever it takes. Just make sure not to lose those GPS trackers.”

Miruko’s gaze swept over all of them, stopping at each pair of determined eyes. “Everyone knows their role. Stick to the plan. Keep your cool. Do not improvise and do not play the hero.”

Everyone nodded then began to gather the last of their gear. When the final gun was secured, Aizawa turned to Katsuki.

The room stilled. All eyes shifted to them.

Aizawa’s hand landed gently on his shoulder. “Are you ready, kid?”

Silence hung for a second.

Katsuki’s jaw locked. His muscles strained. The pressure inside him began building.

Every beat of his heart was pounding, begging to get back to where he called home in Izuku’s arms.

In the back of his mind, he could see him. His lover was waiting for him in the dark shadows, trapped in black fog that wrapped around his wrists and throat. Izuku was stranded there, slowly getting swallowed whole by the darkness as he glanced over his shoulder.

Katsuki curled his fist.

He lifted his head and his eyes gleamed like the edge of a knife.

“I’m ready,” he hissed.“Let’s go crash that goddamn wedding.”

☽ ☽ ☽

Tokyo moved with a different appetite tonight, rumbling with a hunger so dark it seemed the neon itself fed on blood.

Red and violet lights pulsed over the throng, cutting through the cigarette smoke that clawed skyward. Every street funneled toward the underground like a vast throat, and down it spilled every type of predator: gang bosses draped in heavy coats, assassins wearing their knives like

ornaments, women flashing diamond-capped teeth, and men whose katanas caught the city's light as carelessly as a pinky ring.

And above it all hung the blood moon.

The city felt less like Tokyo and more like a marketplace for spirits dredged from the abyss. It was as if they were all monsters allowed to walk unmasked for a single night, basking in the glow of that burning orange eye overhead.

"Holy shit," Sero breathed, eyes blown wide. "What did we walk into?"

"Hell," Monoma answered, folding his voice down. He drew his bandana higher across his nose. "Don't gawk at anyone too long—they'll definitely punch you."

The four of them moved as one, keeping close in the crush of bodies. The current of the crowd was slow but relentless, forcefully sweeping them through alleys that funneled into the familiar part of Hadeus. Buildings Katsuki recognized loomed ahead.

Blood sprayed across the pavement when a shove escalated into a knife fight. They quickly moved out of the way when the crowd closed in and swallowed the altercation whole.

A sequence of firecrackers set off in the distance and the sound was followed by the roar of the crowd surging louder for the ceremony to come.

Katsuki's eyes cut through the press of bodies. Past the sea of faces, he found what he was looking for: a familiar blacked-out club front.

"That one," he said to the group. "The public elevator is in there."

He gave a sharp glance and signaled the others. They all angled toward it, carefully weaving through the rambunctious crowd.

When they breached the club, the darkness grew deeper. The crowd was only thinner by a damn hair, but Katsuki kept his focus. He pointed to the back, where everyone was heading. Batch by batch, people spilled down into the dark elevator, alcohol and drinks in tow.

When it was finally their turn, they gave the password 'inferno' and were shoved in with two other groups.

Katsuki fixed his stare dead ahead while the others let their eyes flick warily around the cage as it sank. Three full minutes ticked by, and the bottom never came. The churn of chains and the drone of machinery scraped at the silence. Shinsou, Sero, and Monoma traded unsure looks.

Then the elevator stopped with a rattle that shook through their bones.

With a mechanical groan, the doors stretched open.

Sound exploded against them immediately. The deep bass of drums. The clammer of voices overlapping.

Others pushed past them, shouting at their friends in the distance. Everyone else began walking off the platform, but the four of them stood at the railing looking at the sea of commotion below.

Thousands of people packed the underground streets, making the crowd above seem like child's play. The air reeked of liquor and banners stamped with the Shie Hassaikai crest draped from every building. Infinite voices clashed and roared over the pounding of taiko drums as the crowd grinned with unrestrained joy.

Katsuki glanced at his friends.

Everyone was taking in the enormous black pillars. The bridges that hung between the columns were bustling with people hollering with grins. And at the ground level, every building was cast in darkness and bright neon lights. But unlike last time Katsuki saw it, the colors of plum and indigo were absent.

Now it was a dazzling crimson, gold, and bright silver filling every nook and cranny.

Katsuki folded his arms as the cold air licked his skin. Beside him, Monoma leaned forward against the rail, wide-eyed with disbelief.

"Holy shit…" Monoma whispered, leaning to look up at the high ceiling. "Has this been down here this whole time?"

"Only the last five years," Katsuki corrected. "The Shie Hassaikai built this with the help of Tomura. According to Izuku, this was the first step of Tomura getting his foot in the door with Chisaki."

Shinsou gave a low, impressive whistle.

"Hey guys," Sero said, pointing to the far side. "I think over there is where the parade is going to be."

At the dead center of Limbo stretched a wide avenue strung with lanterns. Red and gold light bled into the atmosphere, bouncing against the stone walls and painting the faces of the crowd. From here, Katsuki could see that was where the sea of bodies was most dense. Countless bodies were pressed into two neat rows that left a long, clear aisle.

It ran straight down to the massive staircase that led into the circle below.

Katsuki pulled his bandana over his mouth and his eyes darkened.

"Let's go."

☽ ☽ ☽

The four of them shoved shoulder to shoulder through the crowd, swallowed by a tide of sweat, perfume, and sake. Lantern light swung overhead, casting everything in molten red while the deafening boom of drums rattled through their chests. The percussion got louder the further into the dense crowd they pushed, making their ribs feel like hollowed out wood.

Katsuki grimaced. He pulled his bandana tight over his mouth, trying to avoid getting elbowed in the face. But it was damn hard. Every step he took someone stepped on his foot. Or elbowed him in the side.

“Shit,” Sero muttered, wiping sweat from his brow. “Feels like the whole damn country is here.”

“That’s because it is,” Shinsou hissed, his mouth drawn tight. “Seems like the Shie Hassaikai want every witness they can get for their successful acquisition.”

With one final shove, they broke through to the railing.

Katsuki dragged in a breath, sharp and thin, as they pressed against the cold metal. On the other side, Yakuza guards formed a black wall. Intimidating rifles strapped across their chests and sharp Katanas perched on their backs. Their mean eyes scanned the masses like wolves pacing a pen.

The four of them straightened into a row, shoulder to shoulder. They stared down at the empty avenue carved through the chaos.

Monoma looked down at his watch. “Should be starting right about—”

Suddenly, a sharp boom cut through the air.

“…Now,” Monoma finished in a whisper.

The lanterns overhead dimmed all at once, plunging the crowd into a restless hush. Every head tilted upward, waiting. Then—one gong strike. It was low, thunderous, and so deep it snapped the chaos into silence.

A wave of cymbals followed, shattering the stillness. Flutes trilled upwards above the roar that began to swell in the crowd. The lanterns flickered, stuttering like dying stars, then they exploded back to life in a blinding blaze of gold.

A chilling perfect choir of voices cut through the air and the music began.

Dancers poured into the aisle in gleaming silks. The first line spun and bowed as the crowd erupted into unruly cheers. Their golden sleeves rippled like banners in the glow. Every step they took was measured. Every smile was bright as they traced perfect circles and lines that twinkled in the haze.

Behind them came a row of drummers. Their headbands were tied and their bare arms snapped with every strike as the rhythm deepened.

The dancers multiplied. One row. Then two. Then three. They kept coming until the entire street overflowed with leaping figures. The upbeat music rang louder as their sleeves cracked like ribbons in the air.

“Wow,” Sero muttered under his breath as a whirl of masked dancers appeared.

Hundreds of porcelain masks of foxes, demons, and faceless ghosts appeared. The contemporary dancers swayed and enticed, keeping their movements sharp as their feet slapped in rhythm to the rolling drums.

Then the first carriage thundered in.

Drums boomed. Cymbals clashed. And the shouts of the crowd surged into a frenzy.

A palanquin swayed forward, carried high on the shoulders of sweating men.

Off of it draped gold silk and it was made of polished wood. The carriage shone under the golden lanterns as if it were worth more money than the entire country. Fire-breathers flanked the carriage, spitting plumes that burned blue against the underground dark. The smoke danced over everyone's heads before vanishing into the underground's endless height.

Inside sat a man and woman. Their faces were sharp, proud, and eerily perfect.

One glance was all Katsuki needed to know that they were Chisaki Kai's parents. He'd know that fucking crow-like bone structure anywhere. He could see Kai inherited his infuriating apathy from his father and that smug smirk from his mother.

The two elders sat perfectly cross-legged, waving to their adoring masses. All the while, the crowd roared their approval. Confetti rained from the towers above like colored snow, catching in the crowd's hair as the palanquin drifted by on a tide of celebration.

Then came the dragon dancers.

Bright bursts of red, gold, and green exploded into the street. The dragons leapt, coiled, and snapped their jaws. Their eyes glowed in a strangely enchanting way as their tongues flickered. The three dragons made shapes that caused people to scream in delight and the plastered drunks to raise their drinks in reckless abandon.

When one came near, its massive head passed so close that Katsuki could feel the hot brush of air.

"This is massive," Sero murmured, unsettled. "I don't think I really grasped how much influence the Yakuza held until now. Like I knew, but I didn't *know*."

"Yeah," Monoma replied, pale and quiet. "Talk about insane."

The second carriage rolled in.

It was painted deep black and mimicked spilled oil.

Katsuki looked at who was inside and a visceral, violent reaction detonated inside of him.

Chisaki Kai sat within. His hair was slicked back, and his wedding robes were impeccable. He wore what looked like a stupidly expensive montsuki made entirely of silk. It was black and gold with echoes of the Shie Hassaikai's emblem stitched into it. His hand raised in a lazy wave as if the entire world existed only to worship him.

Behind them, the crowd shrieked, and hundreds of arms began reaching towards Chisaki.

The smug tilt of Chisaki's mouth made Katsuki *itch*.

He clenched his jaw so tight it hurt.

"*Tear his goddamn throat out,*" Katsuki's anger hissed inside of his head. "*He took your mother, and now he's trying to take Izuku too*."

His chin tilted down and murder filled his eyes.

Then the music shifted. The steady thunder of drums slithered into something darker and more venomous.

Out marched the Vipers, armed with guns and weapons. They strolled in rows so precise they looked inhuman. Their steps were perfectly in sync as one, and their formation was too clean to the point it sent uncanny chills down Katsuki's spine. Their suits mirrored the Yakuza's formality, but their colors marked the difference: black and silver.

Between them writhed dancers whose bodies bent like things without bones. Their arms curled into serpentine coils and their masks were painted with dripping fangs and forked tongues. Behind them loomed a float—a colossal snake effigy with black scales. It had glass-green eyes and smoke hissed from its gaping jaws.

And there, in the center, Katsuki saw him.

"That's Tomura," he whispered in a low tone. "The one with the machetes strapped to his back."

He jerked his chin towards the bastard and all of the others' eyes followed.

Tomura stood tall, marching in the middle with an older man who matched his eye and hair color. The elder man beside him waved and grinned, basking in the loud cheers and hollers. But beside him, Tomura didn't take part. His eyes were lifeless per usual, but there was a sense of calm inside of them.

Katsuki could tell. The heartless bastard was enjoying this.

"Holy shit, *that's* the guy?" Sero hissed. "He's scary as fuck."

"The Horned Viper suits him," Shinsou said. "I don't think I've ever seen so many tattoos on one person."

Abruptly, Tomura's cut throat eyes slid right towards them.

Katsuki instantly hid his face beneath the brim of his hat, pulse spiking so violently it hurt. The noise of the parade bled out, drowned by the heavy fear of being seen too soon.

Seconds dragged like chains. Finally, he risked a glance. He looked up to see Tomura had marched past without stopping. The parade carried him deeper into the sea of silver and black

without so much as a backward glance.

Katsuki exhaled shakily, his shoulders loosening. But the relief was hollow. His gut was roiled with guilt and bile rose in the back of his throat. No matter how tightly he clenched his teeth, the guilt sat there reminding him of all his mistakes.

And then—a sudden silence. The rumbling crowd died down for a moment, and all the shouts were replaced with whispers and awes.

The final float emerged.

It was a carriage draped in pale silk, glowing as though it carried a precious gem. And when who was inside came into view, Katsuki's heart stopped.

It was Izuku.

He sat on viridian cushions, perfectly framed. He was dressed in a white and gold montsuki. The fabric shimmered like sunlight on water. The robes cinched at his waist and his hair was sculpted into a style Katsuki had never seen, every strand tamed until he looked like a doll.

Somehow, Izuku looked beautiful and devastating all at once.

The crowd broke into cheers as white and red petals rained down in waves. Drums thundered, flutes screamed, and confetti spun through the air like falling stars.

But all Katsuki could see was Izuku.

"We have eyes on the target," Shinsou said, finger pressing against the comm at his ear.

Aizawa's voice crackled through the line, "Good job. How's it looking down there?"

"Crazy," Shinsou replied. "You wouldn't believe how big this place actually is."

Katsuki didn't even realize he'd moved until Monoma's voice barked behind him. He was already tearing through the sea of bodies, hugging the railing. He shadowed the line of men carrying Izuku's carriage with his heart hammering impossibly fast. Every beat of the drums fell in perfect sync with the frantic rhythm in his chest.

If he could get Izuku to see him. One glance—that was all it would take. Just *one*. Then Izuku would know he was here. He'd know this goddamn nightmare was almost over.

Izuku's eyes swept the crowd slowly. Then they locked gazes.

Katsuki's lungs seized and the world stopped cold. For a heartbeat, he swore he saw a flicker of recognition.

And then—

Nothing.

Izuku's gaze stayed tethered to his, but there was no warmth. There was no relief and not even an inkling of surprise. His eyes were out of focus, flat, and blank. Cold green eyes sliced through Katsuki like glass.

Katsuki stopped moving.

An unnerving chill ripped up his spine.

Izuku's eyes never changed. He gazed at Katsuki like he was an omen. And then something darker seeped in. It was disconnected, calculating, and destructive.

Then gradually, Izuku tore his eyes away and stared ahead with empty obedience. More rose petals poured down on him and into the crowd.

Katsuki stayed frozen in place.

"Hey!" Monoma's hand clamped down hard on his shoulder, jerking him around. "Don't wander off like that, Bakugou! The hell got into you?!"

But Katsuki barely heard him. His eyes stayed locked on the fading outline of Izuku's carriage. When Izuku finally vanished into the procession, Katsuki turned his head back towards his unit. They all stared at him like he lost his head, and a knot choked his throat.

"…Something's wrong," Katsuki rasped, voice grave. "Izuku was…off."

"Well, no shit," Monoma shot back in a harsh whisper. "He's been forcefully sold off to the Yakuza as some sort of fucking *bride*. Of course he's off."

Katsuki shook his head, sharp and desperate. "No. You don't get it." His voice cracked with a terror he couldn't mask. "It wasn't that. His eyes—" He swallowed hard and all the color drained from his face. "They were *empty*. It—it was weird. He saw me and he didn't react."

That unsettled everyone.

Uneasy glances passed between the others.

"At all?" Shinsou asked quietly.

"Not at all," Katsuki confirmed.

The roar of the crowd swelled. The cheers multiplied, the petals tripled, and the thunderous applause swelled louder. The parade blurred into a maelstrom of noise and color, surging forward towards the grand staircase that led deeper into Hadeus.

"C'mon," Monoma commanded, pulling their focus back. "We have to stick tight to the parade. We can't let Izuku out of our sight."

Everyone nodded, adjusting to the current of the crowd. Katsuki followed along, keeping close to his crew. However, he couldn't shake the unnerving feeling that Izuku's eyes gave him.

That hollow, lifeless stare clawed at his throat, gnawing at him with every beat of the drums.

☽ ☽ ☽

The four of them pressed onward, shoving through the rowdy crowd as the parade siphoned deeper into Hadeus. As they descended, the air grew heavier, and the neon glow from the underground city transformed into sharp streaks of red and gold. The energy from the crowd didn't die down either. It amped up, growing more and more boisterous as they dropped from the first circle and then to the second.

When they reached the belly of the third circle, the green lights shone down on the parade brightly.

"Hey guys," Denki crackled through the line. "Your intercoms are about to go out when you reach the fourth circle. I'll still be able to see your trackers, but you're about to go dark with us."

"Got it," Monoma replied, holding down the com button. "We'll be sure to communicate the moment we re-breech."

"Don't die down there," Miruko replied.

And like expected, the moment they reached the fourth circle, the intercoms went dead. For a heartbeat, Katsuki could feel the tick of dead seriousness in their crew. If things hadn't become real before, they were now. Katsuki drew himself up, shoulders rigid.

"No mistakes now," Shinsou muttered. "Everyone stay sharp."

Katsuki's jaw tightened. Sero's hands flexed. Monoma's eyes narrowed.

The parade surged forward, and finally, the procession approached the opening to the ninth circle. In the large foyer, hundreds of bodies pressed together. Everyone stopped in front of two massive black doors made of obsidian. They loomed ahead, towering taller than anything Katsuki had seen.

The parade crinkled on itself, and the dancers mixed with the crowd. The Yakuza guards build a wall again, allowing the carriages to separate a healthy distance from the masses.

Through the hundreds of bodies, Katsuki shakily could only get a glimpse of what was happening ahead.

The people in the carriages walked out, waving at the crowd. First, the Chisakis. They smiled and like a mirror, all their adoring underground masses waved back.

Chisaki Kai walked over to the carriage holding Izuku and stretched out his hand.

Delicately, Izuku emerged. He walked off the carriage and was helped upright. His mouth was forced into a small smile as he looked on to the crowd. He waved back as well, causing swoons to ricochet from person to person.

All the cheering made Katsuki sicker and sicker.

Because, Izuku's eyes were dull. And nobody seemed to notice.

Chisaki and Izuku stood side by side flanked by a phalanx of Yakuza and Vipers.

With a loud creek, the grand doors to the ninth circle opened, swinging wide like they were the gates of hell.

An eerie, almost poisonous green light poured out from beyond the threshold.

Around four hundred people walked forward, showing something in their hands. From this distance, Katsuki could only make out what appeared to be invitations printed in black, gold, and green. The armed guards ushered inside, one by one, every person who held an invite.

Those without invites began slowly retreating back into the upper circles. They continued on celebrating, as if this was a national holiday for the Tokyo Underground.

Katsuki's gaze flicked to Izuku.

The other man was still standing rigid beside Chisaki Kai.

Katsuki's heart pounded, and every instinct screamed: get in there, now. Fury simmered in his veins. It spilled into his lungs until every breath felt like goddamn fire.

When the last guest walked inside, it was then Chisaki and Izuku's turn. Together, they passed over the threshold, and the grand doors slowly closed.

Izuku took one last glance over his shoulder into the crowd.

Their eyes met.

For a brief, painful breath, it felt like the world narrowed to that single, impossible connection.

They didn't break contact as the doors slid shut, swallowing Izuku whole.

"Attention wedding dancers and entertainment!" A sudden voice boomed.

All eyes turned to a large yakuza guard with a giant 'mom' neck tattoo. He stood tall with a megaphone, bringing the clamoring crowd to a low murmur.

"If you're scheduled to perform later, proceed upstairs to the eighth floor as instructed! Come back here at the required time after the wedding ceremony is finished for the reception."

Katsuki's gaze snapped to Monoma. Their eyes locked and the same thought struck them both.

The mass began to shift again, a tide of performers drifting up the wide staircase. Those not scheduled to return, peeled away entirely. They vanished into the crowd with drunken

laughter and celebratory shouts.

The rest broke off at the eighth circle, filing into an empty plaza bathed in neon haze.

Keeping low, Katsuki's crew shadowed them.

They slipped into the cover of a nearby building. From there, they watched as drummers, acrobats, fire-breathers, and exactly one dragon collapsed into the street outside a roaring bar.

With a loud huff, the dragon's painted silk covering sagged to the ground and revealed the four sweaty dancers underneath. One wiped his brow with the back of his hand, another hacked out a cough, a third squatted with a groan of relief. But the last stood tall, hands braced on his hips, not winded in the slightest.

"Shit, man, my feet are killing me," one groaned.

"Same," another muttered. "It took forever to get all the way down here."

The upright dancer leveled a stern look at them. "We need to practice."

His words drew a chorus of groans. The others stared at him like he'd lost his mind. Some other dancers nearby laughed, excused themselves, and drifted toward the bar. Three of the dragon dancers glared after them with equal parts jealousy and frustration.

"Really, Mori? *Again*?" one of the teammates protested. "We've gone over this a hundred times."

Mori huffed, folding his arms with authority. "As president of the Celestial Dragonfire Dance Collective, what I say goes. And I say we practice until the last available second. If one of you screws up because you're clumsy, I'm not losing my head for it." His gaze cut to the woman with a high ponytail. "I'm talking to *you*, Chiyo."

"Me?" she sputtered, offended. "I am not clumsy!" She looked around for support, but her teammates all grimaced and averted their eyes. Her jaw dropped. "*Seriously*? No one is going to back me up?"

"Well…" the other woman sighed. "You did mess up during the parade."

"No one noticed that!" Chiyo shot back.

"Yeah, well, people will notice when we're dancing with the newlyweds for their first dance," Mori snapped, stepping closer. "If your two left feet land on *Chisaki Kai*, it'll be all our heads on the chopping block."

Chiyo threw her hands up in defeat. "Fine! Let's go practice for the billionth time. Whatever."

Grumbling, the group lifted the dragon costume again and trudged toward a quiet section of the circle.

From the shadows, Katsuki and the others traded looks.

Monoma's mouth slid into a grin as he drew his gun and arched a brow. "Looks like we're about to learn a dance."

☽ ☽ ☽

The dance crew moved to a secluded open area to practice. It was fairly simple. A step here, a step there. The dragon was long and when all four were in sync well enough, it could make a full circle with the tail touching the head.

From a nearby alley, their unit observed. They memorized every subtle sway and the beat that the dancers were counting to.

In the open space, Mori barked instructions like a drill sergeant as the head of the dragon. He loudly counted off moves while the others shuffled with half-hearted groans.

"Left, right, pivot—no, no, Chiyo, your timing is still garbage!" he snapped.

"Oh my god, Mori, nobody cares!" Chiyo groaned, nearly tripping over the tail section.

Katsuki leaned on the edge of the alley wall, arms crossed. His eyes narrowed as he studied every movement.

Monoma tilted his head. "I can't believe our way in will be interpretive lizard dancing."

"It's a dragon," Sero corrected.

"Dragons are still lizards."

"No they're not—"

"—Shut up, both of you," Katsuki growled, mind locked on Izuku's face still burned into his skull.

The practice went on for a while, making all of them check their watches. According to the schedule Denki obtained, the wedding ceremony was coming to a close soon, and the reception would be starting. The push of urgency pressed down like a hand on the back of all their necks. It gripped tighter and tighter with every ticking second.

Finally, the dragon dropped to the ground. The dancers slugged it off their bodies and one of the women checked the time and groaned.

"Okay. We gotta head back," she said. "It's almost the end of the ceremony."

That was their opening.

"Now," Katsuki hissed.

They moved. The four of them burst from the alley, guns drawn. Immediately, all the dancers screamed and panicked. Katsuki lifted his gun directly to one of the dancer's heads, and Sero pressed his against the startled ribs of another. Before any of the dancers could squeak further, each one of them was staring down the barrel of a gun, entirely encircled.

Mori's mouth dropped open, but Monoma shoved his pistol further into the man's face.

"Careful," Monoma warned with a smirk. "Make another sound and you'll be dancing with a hole in your eye for the rest of your life."

They raised their hands, and the dragon collapsed to the ground.

Quickly, their unit worked fast. They drew from their backpacks rope and duck tape. With the press of time on their backs, they moved efficiently. In minutes, they dragged the dancers into a narrow alley far out of sight and took their phones.

They pushed them to the ground and tied all their wrists and ankles. With silver strips, their mouths were sealed tight, muffling their protests and scared cries. Some of them tried to scream for help, but the loudness of Hadeus swallowed the sound.

And as the final touch, each of them tore the badge that read 'entertainment' from the dancers' necks.

Monoma gave a little mock bow to their captives.

"Enjoy your break," he said dryly. "We'll take it from here."

☽ ☽ ☽

"Does everyone understand the new plan?" Shinsou asked.

"Yeah, we're ready," Katsuki replied.

Monoma and Sero nodded as well.

The four of them hurried, lifting the collapsed dragon between their hands before ducking under the silk in one practiced motion. Shinsou claimed the head, Monoma grumbled his way to the tail, and Katsuki and Sero filled the middle, shoulders hunched to keep the costume steady.

They shuffled forward, awkward at first, then eventually found a clumsy rhythm that at least resembled the dancers they'd studied. Passing through the crowded circle, they ignored the drunken cheers and half-slurred catcalls that followed them. Strangers tossed out jokes, toasts, and jeers at the wobbling dragon weaving past.

"Great job out there!" One man with a deep voice shouted.

With a sly grin a woman slapped the back of Monoma's ass as they passed.

"Can you give me a lift on your magic dragon ride?" She teased.

Dark chuckles surrounded them. But they ignored them all and pushed down towards the ninth circle. When the double doors came into view again, the rest of the entertainers were already lined up.

The guard with the neck tattoo prowled down the row, eyes sharp despite the chaos. He held a clipboard, ticking boxes one by one. When he reached them, sweat gathered on their foreheads.

“Badge?” The guard asked, automatically suspicious.

Katsuki dipped his hand from below the covering and held up the stolen pass with a steady hand.

For a beat, the guard’s gaze lingered. Then he gave a curt nod and waved them through.

“Okay, that’s everyone,” he announced, tucking the clipboard under his arm. “Follow me. We’ll be going through the side doors. Do not speak and do not interrupt the ceremony.”

The guard moved towards a narrow, shadowed corridor beside the massive double doors. They wound through the tight passage, walls swallowing the light. They walked until they came to a small set of doors. From beyond, a muted hum of chants seeped through.

The Yakuza guard held the doors open. One by one, they slipped inside the modest room.

A few chairs were scattered about, and a large white curtain separated this space from the main hall. Beyond the veil, the chanting persisted, thick and solemn.

Some of the dancers cautiously peered from behind the curtain, careful not to draw attention.

Even the guard leaned in slightly, curiosity tugging at him.

“Someone should take a look,” Shinsou suggested in a whisper. “Sero or Bakugou. One of you peek your head under and see what’s happening.”

They shuffled to the other side of the curtains, away from the Yakuza guard. Carefully, Katsuki lifted the silk of the dragon and poked his head out.

He peered around the curtains and was met with one of the most horrifying images.

The room beyond was a ceremony hall. Every surface was decorated in green, white, and gold. Bright marble tiles stretched endlessly down the aisle, reflecting the glow of lanterns that were shaped like lilies. They hung suspended between towering green-veined columns. Gold decorations traced the ribs of the ceiling and the edges of the altar. Along the aisle were silk runners of emerald and white that led the eye forward.

Guests filled the benches. Every single damn person was dressed in a sharp suit or flowing gown. There was a mix of formal attire and silk kimonos. Each outfit looked deliberately chosen to echo their wealth and status.

And at the end of the aisle, were two figures at the altar.

Izuku and Chisaki knelt side by side, wrists bound together with a single strand of red thread that the priest looped and tightened with deliberate care.

The priest's voice rang clearly over the gathered crowd.

"By this thread, your lives are intertwined," he recited. "Your hearts are bound and your destinies are one."

Every inch of the hall clapped, but Izuku didn't react.

He knelt there with a restrained, rigid posture. Katsuki could see the faint line of tension in his shoulders and the unnatural blank stare in his eyes. The vows drifted between them like they were made of nothing. Sweet, hollow poetry meant for everyone else, but did not match the dead look in Izuku's eyes.

Katsuki's gaze stayed locked and his heart began to beat loudly.

When the priest gave one last line, both Izuku and Chisaki stood. They turned to each other.

Chisaki lifted his free hand and caressed Izuku's cheek.

"You are now officially wed," the priest declared.

A roar of cheers erupted as all the guests stood up, clapping. Katsuki watched with a lump in his throat as once again, he was stuck witnessing Chisaki kiss Izuku. The man leaned in, and his hand weaved greedily through Izuku's curls.

But unlike last time, Izuku barely responded. He stood there as Chisaki took it all and closed his eyes. Katsuki's jaw tightened. His fist curled and every muscle in his body screamed to run forward.

And then—he saw it.

It was a flicker. A small, almost imperceptible pulse of resistance.

Izuku's eyes were shut, but at his side, his hand clenched into a fist.

Katsuki's heart kicked up. Izuku was still fighting.

"Alright time for everyone to go," The Yakuza guard said to the room. "We're going to shuffle in the reception with all the guests now. Follow everyone through the doors."

The whole of the wedding party and guests moved through a new set of doors. The entryway opened inside the ceremonial chamber, leading everyone further into the ninth circle.

The Yakuza guard herded them all like a Shepard. They shuffled from behind the curtain to follow the hundreds of guests. As one, they all poured into the new hall and Katsuki couldn't see shit. He did his best not to step on Shinsou's heels as his colleague led them into the room.

When the Yakuza guard ushered them into the corner and told them to wait for their signal, Katsuki discreetly poked his head out to glimpse at the room. His eyes scanned the exits and found exactly three.

“There’s open doors in front of the dance floor,” he whispered. “I think that’s going to be our escape route.”

Sero and Monoma carefully peered out too.

Stunned by the sight, Sero gave a low whistle. “I hate to say it, but the Yakuza have great taste.”

The reception hall was much grander than the ceremonial hall.

The room was entirely black. Streaks of gold and deep viridian were the only things that broke this up. The two colors scattered about in flowers and vines that hung from the ceiling. Candles were placed all around, adding to the glow of chandeliers that were dripping with emeralds. The gems cast fractured light across the space, making it look like the entire room was full of green stars.

Dozens of tables for the guests scattered along either side of the room, hugging a black marble dance floor. The tables were impossibly polished and their surfaces were alive with centerpieces of deep green and glinting gold. Gold and green roses ran in neat rows down each table, petals curling as if to drink in the light.

And at the head of the hall was a singular, elevated dinner table.

It was obvious who it was for with the way it was highlighted under the brightest of lights. Its surface was donned with a viridian tablecloth, perfectly lined roses, and large beautiful candles.

Overall, the reception hall in Katsuki’s opinion, was horrifying.

Every element of it. The deep greens. The blinding gold. It screamed that type of extravagance Katsuki was always disgusted by.

“What a waste,” Monoma mumbled under his breath.

All around them, the hundreds of guests took their seats. A tide of polite chatter and carefully curated smiles rippled through the hall from person to person.

Chisaki took Izuku’s hand, guiding him to the elevated table at the front.

Then, from behind, the clatter of wheels and footsteps drew attention.

Katsuki’s eyes narrowed instinctively and he turned his head.

And there he saw the largest damn cake he’s ever seen. His eyes tracked it across the polished marble floor. It was a giant, five-tier tower of light green frosting banded with deep emerald fondant designs. Every single corner of it was crowned with sculpted sugar roses.

The hall erupted in whistles as the cake reached the center.

As he looked at the two black roses on top, Izuku's heart churned.

A subtle twist of unease bloomed in his stomach, making his body shift ever so slightly in his chair. He was careful to keep the mask fixed on his face.

"How are you feeling, beautiful?" Chisaki's voice broke the moment. The scent of his cologne wafted into Izuku's senses. "You seem a bit dazed."

Izuku blinked and focused on the words. He forced his lips into a smile and turned to his new husband.

"I'm feeling perfect," he lied softly. "I just can't believe this is all happening. It feels… surreal, after so long."

Chisaki smiled at him, and placed a warm hand over his. "It does. I'm happy we could finally get here. I still remember the first day I saw you. Seems like it's been a long time coming."

Izuku glanced at the cake.

"It does," he said sincerely. "A very much deserved time."

The lights dimmed slightly, drawing everyone's attention toward the center of the room.

A pang of unease tightened in his gut as the crowd's chatter hushed and the MC stepped forward. The man was tall, lanky, and dressed with a dark purple suit and a high bun. His teeth gleamed unnaturally white under the emerald chandeliers. Without wasting time, he began speaking in a polished, relentless drone about life, dedication, and the power of the Chisaki legacy.

He even said how *lucky* Izuku was.

How fortunate they all were.

Izuku only half-listened. His mind started to fray at the edges, reality feeling thin.

On the way here, Izuku saw the phantom of Katsuki yet again. Twice. The ghost followed him the whole way down the parade like an ominous shadow beckoning to him. And when the door shut right before the ceremony—Izuku saw him again.

Beautiful scarlet eyes were trying to bring him back home.

Seeing that last vision of Katsuki was the final push Izuku needed.

He knew where he belonged, and it wasn't here.

Applause rippled through the room at the MC's carefully timed exit joke. After the MC sat down, the reception trudged forward in a blur of speeches, clinking wine glasses, and waves of food.

First came the appetizers. Bloody Mary shooters, oysters and olives dripped in a savory glaze called ‘venom’ as a cute play on words for the Vipers. Next came the first course. A choice of greek-salad or garlic soup. Then finally out came the entrée. Seared filet mignon topped with wild mushroom bleu cheese.

During dinner, Izuku allowed Chisaki to hold his hand while his attention drifted. Chisaki’s fingers tightened and loosened in an unconscious rhythm as he listened to his parents give some heart warming speech. They cooed about how proud they were of their son for how far he expanded the Shie Hassaikai.

As they ate, dancers fluttered across the marble floor as entertainment.

The echo of drums filled the hall with cheers. Across the floor, low smoke from the fog machine rolled out to make it all feel more enchanting and extravagant.

Beside him, Chisaki smiled, satisfied.

About halfway through the performances, Izuku caught Tomura across the room. His brother was seated next to Zen and the other important members of The Viper Academy. He leaned back in his chair with his hands neatly folded on the table. He looked onward at the dancers, not entirely entertained but not entirely bored.

As if he could feel Izuku staring, he cut his eyes over to him.

Tomura gave him a polite, small wave.

Izuku smiled back sadly. He returned the wave.

The performances cycled on. Each group was more elaborate than the last, making an effort to dazzle the Chisakis and get in good with their favor.

When the last group got a standing ovation, the MC returned to the center of the floor. He raised his hand like a conductor.

“Now it’s time for dessert!” he called. “Can I get the lovely couple up here to cut the cake?”

Izuku felt the weight of every eye in the room turn to him.

They rose and Chisaki guided him by his hand down to the center of the floor. All around, the emerald speckles shone just for this moment as they grew closer and closer to the cake. When they got right on it, it felt like it was alive. It towered over him, and Izuku needed to crane his neck to see the top.

On the small table beside it sat a single plate, a knife, and two forks.

Chisaki picked up the knife. He pressed it into Izuku’s palm before curling his own hand firmly around his. He forcefully turned Izuku around, slotting his back against his chest. With his two arms, he caged Izuku in and turned them both toward the towering cake. The crowd awed.

Together, as one, their hands pushed the blade through.

As the knife cut down, Izuku's eyes drifted over the sea of onlookers.

He saw Zen, happy. Tomura, approving. The Chisakis, adoring.

And for a moment, Izuku searched for Hiryu's phantom.

Would his lost brother come to him again? He wondered if the side of him that protected him from death all these years would surge forward. Maybe it'd come running, knock the cake out of his hand, and tell him he needed to survive—tell him he needed to live.

But the longer he searched the sea of unfamiliar faces, he couldn't find Hiryu.

And he knew why.

He couldn't find any more will to survive inside of him.

Instead, in the reflection of the cheering crowd, he saw Katsuki. He saw all the versions of his husband that were stolen from him.

The crowd cheered again as the first slice of cake was officially cut. Chisaki grinned brightly as he helped guide Izuku's hand. The green cake was placed neatly on the golden plate, and his new husband held up the dessert for all to see. The crowd clapped some more as Chisaki stabbed the sweet dessert with a fork.

Slowly, Izuku picked up the fork too. He took a piece off, and they held gazes.

Izuku smiled sweetly and Chisaki returned it.

Together, they fed each other a bite of cake.

The crowd whistled as the new couple chewed and swallowed together. Izuku blinked back tears as they did this three more times until the slice was entirely gone.

Between the two of them, they ate exactly half a slice each.

Chisaki licked his lips and nodded, humming in satisfaction.

"It's sweeter than I expected," he said. "I'll have to ask the chef for their recipe."

Izuku laughed, genuinely from his stomach.

The staff swept in and with large knives they started to sever the giant cake. Two slices were set aside for Izuku and Chisaki, and hand in hand they returned to their seats.

From his chair at the head table, Izuku could see it all.

The staff moved in clean, efficient lines. They set down slices before all four hundred of their guests. Some dug in at once, grinning with mouths already full. But others lingered in chatter,

their utensils hovering before they gave in. Within minutes, fork marks marred nearly every slice of cake.

He watched them eat, running calculations as everyone consumed the cake in different portions.

Half a slice. An hour and a half.

Full slice. An hour, maybe less.

But then a few nibbled. Ms. Nagant took a single bite, wiped her lips, and stared ahead. Mr. Compress did the same, and they began casually talking.

Izuku pressed his lips in a thin line. They would be gone exactly at midnight.

His eyes slid to Zen.

His father was on his second slice.

Izuku's eyes turned to Tomura, and his heart stuttered.

His brother wasn't eating.

The feeling of being pushed over a cliff rose inside of Izuku. He blinked a bit, wondering if maybe Tomura was full, or worse, if Tomura knew he'd poisoned the cake.

However, when Zen nudged Tomura, asking if he'd eat the untouched slice, the answer came. Tomura slid his plate across the table without hesitation, smiling faintly as he offered it up—completely ignorant. Zen chewed happily on his third slice, and Izuku felt a sense of satisfaction watching him swallow.

"This cake is so good," Chisaki mumbled eloquently. He continued to eat another slice, and smiled with his eyes at Izuku. "Do you not want any more? You only had half a slice."

Izuku faked a charming smile. "I'm very full from dinner. But I would love some later."

"Of course, I'll have some of the servants save you as much cake as you want."

As the guests continued their dessert feast, it was time for photos. The MC called up people table by table for a picture with Izuku and Chisaki.

First came the Chisaki family, of course. Kurenai pressed a kiss to Izuku's cheek while Takeshi offered a simple nod. They gathered close around their son, and the flash caught their prideful composure.

Next came the endless parade of uncles, aunts, cousins, and distant relatives. Each new family member smiled happily for the camera. Then at last, the entire clan assembled for a single sweeping portrait. They formed a cluster of dark suits and silks with Izuku and Kai sitting like ornaments at the center.

After that, a ripple of chatter swept through the room as the governor of Tokyo approached.

Izuku still remembered the man from the last time he saw him in passing during the masquerade. He still looked the same. Rosy cheeks, sharp nose, and slicked-back black hair. On his arm tonight was his wife, elegant in deep emerald silk. Her bow was as graceful as her husband's.

The governor inclined his head. "Izuku. It has been far too long. I'm glad we finally have the chance to speak properly."

Izuku bowed in return, his voice even. "As am I, sir. I hope you're enjoying the evening. Please—there's plenty of cake to celebrate with."

"I'll be sure to." The governor chuckled, eyes roaming over Izuku with open approval. "Forgive me if this is sentimental, but I still remember when you were a boy, watching you pass the final exam at The Academy. You stood out even then, and now…well, it's clear you've made a remarkable match." His gaze flicked to Chisaki. "One that suits all of our shared interests."

Chisaki's laugh was low, measured. "Then it seems I owe you thanks, governor. I'll see that a gift is sent your way as a special thanks."

The governor's grin widened, bright and wolfish. "There's no need. Let's simply continue working together. We can speak of our future endeavors later."

They all took a photo together with the governor standing proudly behind Izuku.

Next came the Vipers.

Zen and Tomura rose together, adjusting the lapels of their suits as they made their way forward. Zen greeted Chisaki with a booming laugh, speaking to him like a fond uncle, recounting how honored he was to have watched him grow into the man he'd become.

While they talked, Izuku's gaze drifted toward Tomura's empty plate at the table.

He looked up at his brother.

"You don't want any of the cake?" Izuku asked.

Tomura tilted his head, then shrugged casually.

"No," Tomura answered. He gave Izuku a small, genuine smile. "Matcha isn't really my flavor. I'll drink some more of the dessert wine to celebrate instead."

Izuku's stomach knotted.

He grew quiet, unsure of what to say.

Of course. Somehow, *always somehow*, Tomura remained invincible. Izuku didn't know if he should push. He didn't want to risk looking too suspicious—so he didn't. Instead, he gave his

brother a sincere smile for the first time in over a month.

At least when all this was over, Tomura wouldn't have his empire. The Chisakis would be gone. So would Zen and the Vipers. Everything would be in shambles, and maybe, just maybe, Tomura would be the one left standing in the wreckage, blamed for it all. Perhaps the Chisakis who couldn't make the wedding on such short notice would point the finger at him.

"Alright, let's take this photo," Zen said cheerfully.

He stepped behind Chisaki and clasped his hands neatly at his back. Tomura walked around and stood behind Izuku. From there, he patted Izuku's shoulders, then rested his hands there. They all posed and smiled for the photo.

The flash went off, and Tomura gave his shoulders one last squeeze.

The two walked away, and next in line were Vipers Izuku knew from home. They all gave half smiles, or full-on stale faces. He heard a couple of comments from his siblings. Under their breath, they snidely called him the 'untouchable' viper. He hadn't heard that callous nickname in a while, but he supposed through their eyes, that's what he was.

In the middle of what felt like the hundredth photo, movement flickered at the edge of Izuku's vision.

His stomach sank when he caught sight of a pair of staff slipping toward the cake, trying to steal away a slice.

He tightened his grip on Chisaki's hand.

"What is it?" Chisaki asked, glancing down.

Izuku leaned closer and lowered his voice. "I don't mean to be rude, but…I think some of the staff are taking the cake. I was hoping to save some for later—"

"—They're *what*?" Chisaki cut him off, tone sharp enough to draw blood. His eyes snapped toward the floor in time to catch a woman in grey attempting to shuffle away.

With a snap of his fingers, the Yakuza guards materialized at his side. He pointed directly at her, lips curling with disdain.

"Remind the servants—*again*—that the food is not for them," Chisaki spat. "They can eat tomorrow. Tonight, it belongs to the guests who matter. Go reprimand them."

Izuku pressed his lips into a thin line as the guards stormed off. Their barked orders scattered the staff like they were frightened animals. Several of the staff's shoulders hunched in shame, and some were even dragged out, shoved toward the doors. Others dropped their heads and slunk back into place.

A sigh slipped past Izuku before he could stop it, soft and resigned.

He forced himself to lean back and smile up at Chisaki. "Thank you."

“Of course,” Chisaki replied. “I’m glad you noticed. We told them to eat a large breakfast before they came into work today because they wouldn’t be served, but it seems like a few didn’t listen. I’ll have those punished further tomorrow.”

Izuku blinked once and buried the twist of disgust under his diplomatic smile.

When the photographs ended, the lights dimmed once more.

His stomach gave a low, unsettled groan. He pressed a hand to it, releasing a shaky breath through his teeth. A glance at the endless sea of faces made the ticking inside his head grow louder. Then he took one look at the clock on the wall and confirmed what he already knew.

At midnight, this would all be over.

His hand curled tight against the silk of his clothes, fingers digging hard enough to crease the fabric.

The fog machines hissed, sending another wave across the floor. It cloaked the reception hall until it looked as though the entire gathering floated on a glittering cloud of emerald light.

The MC strode back onto the floor. His purple suit gleamed faintly beneath the spotlight as though he too had been conjured out of smoke.

“Now,” the MC announced, voice booming as he lifted the microphone. “We come to a very special moment in our program. Everyone, get your handkerchiefs ready—it’s time for the first dance!”

Applause erupted, rippling through the hall. Chisaki gave a poised wave before taking Izuku’s hand. At the same time, they rose and crossed the room towards the center of the dance floor. As they moved, fog swirled at their ankles, drawing them close together.

The spotlight flared down on them, blinding Izuku in its brilliance.

The drums started first, building up in a sweet yet haunting way.

With the ankle monitor still blinking, Izuku moved stiffly into position. One hand was in Chisaki’s and the other trembled at his side.

From the fog, the dragon emerged.

It slithered out in a great sweep of silk. Its head snapped upward, baring its teeth that were painted in vivid celebratory reds and blacks. The body rippled behind, every scale catching the chandeliers’ light so that it seemed alive.

The audience applauded as the beast weaved between the tables. It moved in rhythm with the drums and hymns, every ripple of silk perfectly timed to the spell binding beat.

A melody joined the drums and the whole room became enchanted.

Chisaki's hand pressed into the small of Izuku's back, pushing them close. Their hearts met through the wedding garments and their eyes met. Izuku began swaying with Chisaki underneath the watchful eye of everyone. They turned and stepped. Twirled and dipped.

With every beat of the drum, Izuku counted down the clock to the poison settling in.

The dragon swept onto the floor with them, its long body gliding through the fog. It circled the outer edge, then drew closer and closer through a running spiral. Soon, it joined them in their orbit.

It circled once, twice, each pass tighter than the last.

Quickly, the world faded with every spin. Out of the corner of his eye, Izuku saw the dragon drawing nearer. He frowned slightly when the dragon tightened its arc, brushing too close to his waist. He ignored it, but then it happened again. It drew closer as it passed behind him and its tail coiled tighter.

Izuku faltered slightly.

This wasn't part of the dance.

He knew because he'd watched the rehearsal twenty-seven times.

Chisaki leaned in to whisper something, but Izuku didn't hear it at all. All he could feel was the weight of the dragon pressing in too close.

Then the lights dimmed further.

Both their heads snapped up at the same time colorful smoke bombs exploded across the floor in perfect sync with the percussion.

The guests cheered and the room lit up with bright, red and gold sparklers, making vision low. Izuku tried to squint but he couldn't see out to the audience now, which meant they could not see them either. All that there was was a dense red smog, blocking them off from the rest of the world as the music grew deafening.

Chisaki finally slowed his dancing as well. He looked around as the dragon blocked them in entirely.

He frowned. "Did you change the choreography last minute?"

"No." Izuku shook his head. "You didn't request the smoke bombs and sparklers?"

Then suddenly, someone dipped from the middle of the dragon directly behind Chisaki. A shadow in stepped forward through the smoke, unfolding to be as pitch black as night.

When it rose to full height, deadly scarlet eyes cut through the smoke.

Izuku's breath caught. His mouth parted.

Chisaki saw Izuku's ghastly expression too late.

He half-turned, confused—but the person was already there. In a blur of fury, the distance was closed in the blink of an eye. Katsuki erupted into view like a phoenix rising from ash, eyes blazing, and every muscle in his face was etched in murderous intent.

There was no chance to react.

Katsuki hammered his blade deep into Chisaki's throat, the steel tearing through flesh with a wet crack.

Time shattered.

Izuku stood frozen, arms suspended midair.

Chisaki gurgled, choking on his own blood. He desperately clawed at the steel lodged in his neck and his mouth tried to make sounds for help. But the loud drums overshadowed every bit of his cries. His eyes bulged as his terrified gaze dragged upward—and found Katsuki.

Katsuki leaned in so near that he could feel the shudder of Chisaki's final breath against his cheek.

"I was always told I had my mother's eyes," Katsuki whispered, lips twisted in a vicious sneer. "Tell me—do you see her in me?"

He twisted the knife deeper. The name carved into its hilt—*Mitsuki*—caught the light.

Chisaki's stare went wide with terror. His veins strained as he tried to form a reply that never came. His hands flailed weakly at Katsuki's chest, nails scraping but finding no purchase. The air between them filled with the sound of Chisaki's dying breaths and the sound of his flesh tearing as Katsuki drove the blade deeper and deeper, cutting every artery in his neck.

With one brutal wrench, he tore the blade free.

Blood sprayed across Izuku's face, staining his white ceremonial clothes in scarlet.

Blood poured in a thick, unbroken stream onto Chisaki's chest. Down, down, down it went all the way to the floor. He staggered back and clasped both hands around his bleeding throat. Before he could turn, Katsuki shot a hand out and shoved him down to the floor like he was nothing. Chisaki's knees buckled and he hit the ground in beat with the drums.

At all their feet, blood pooled beneath them in a widening halo.

Chisaki's eyes found Izuku for an instant and then they rolled back into his skull. His body convulsed once more in a grotesque final shudder—then he went utterly still.

Izuku froze, stunned into a state of shock.

His breath caught in his throat as his eyes locked onto the figure standing before him. Katsuki's eyes burned with unrelenting savagery. For a heartbeat—no, for an *eternity* he

could not believe what he saw. His mind screamed it couldn't be real, that this was another cruel hallucination as he inched towards death.

But his body betrayed him. His hands began to tremble and reached out before he could stop them. He was desperate in the worst, most hopeless way for the impossible to be true.

"Katsuki?" he whispered, his voice cracking apart.

And then the figure moved, and it turned out not to be a ghost at all.

A strong hand closed around Izuku's wrist anchoring him to reality.

"Let's get the fuck out of here," Katsuki hissed.

Chapter End Notes

Let me know your thoughts/screams/theories below! We're buckling up hard the next chapter!! ^^

Chapter 47: Fortissimo

Chapter Summary

> Fortissimo (Stylistic indicator) — To play very loudly

Chapter Notes

> Hellllooooo! Welcome to *drumroll*....Part 1 of the climax!!
>
> First, thank you to the LOML, Luna, for betaing this chapter like always! I'm so glad we're finally here and I'm so overjoyed. Words can't describe how much fun I had writing this chapter. I hope you enjoy reading it!
>
> **Warnings: Violence**

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 47 — Fortissimo

.

.

.

Izuku lost his balance as he was forcibly dragged under the dragon.

He looked around, dazed and confused. But he couldn’t find an inkling of sense. All around him, the world blurred into smoke and Chisaki’s blood. The two fused to make an impossible conclusion. Katsuki? Katsuki was *alive*? He tried to grasp it, but he couldn’t. All he could feel was the bruising pressure of Katsuki’s hands at his waist, desperately shoving him forward.

“Alright, we gotta *move*. Everyone kick it in gear!”

Izuku’s head snapped up. That was Shinsou’s voice.

He looked in front, towards the head of the dragon—and there he was. Shinsou was standing tall, pulling them fast. Suddenly, the whole dragon convulsed into a frantic, jolting sprint. Izuku tripped over his own feet, breath catching in his throat. But Katsuki held him steady and pushed harder until his legs fell into rhythm.

They bolted out of the reception hall in a blaze, and immediately the dragon was thrown to the ground.

There was only a second to look back. There, the entrance to the hall was clouded with colorful smoke. Blues, reds, and greens blocked the view while the deafening drums still hammered on. From within, sounds of confusion slowly rose.

But that's all Izuku could decipher before he was dragged by the wrist.

Katsuki began running, and so did Shinsou.

Izuku forced his legs to obey, lungs hitching as his thoughts lagged several beats behind.

He barely registered Sero and Monoma beside them. Their expressions were stripped of humor, and their eyes were fixed dead ahead. In front of them, Shinsou took the lead. He held a device in his hand that glowed with a map. They ran through narrow corridors that bent and twisted. Every turn was more disorienting than the last until they were spit out into the foyer of the Ninth Circle.

Izuku tried to continue running up the stairs, but Katsuki abruptly grabbed his shoulders.

"We gotta get him out of this before the smoke clears," Katsuki said urgently. "We don't have much time."

Before Izuku could question what that meant, Katsuki whirled him around in a dizzying spin. In the blink of an eye, he was stripped of his wedding hoari. Izuku grew more confused when the garment was frantically tossed to Monoma—who was fastening a green wig on his head.

Katsuki's hands were on him again. He ripped the top layers from Izuku's body until Izuku stood only in his hakama pants and undershirt.

Monoma shrugged into the discarded robes, transforming with startling speed.

Izuku tried to speak, but was cut off. With inhuman efficiency, Katsuki shoved his arms through a hoodie. And then with a harsh snap, he pulled the hood over Izuku's head and yanked the zipper up to his chin.

Screams split the air.

"That's our cue," Shinsou hissed. He flicked a quick nod toward Katsuki. "See you on the surface."

Katsuki curtly nodded and seized Izuku's wrist.

The five of them bolted up the stairs to the Eighth Circle. Behind them, a stampede rumbled. Screams, shouts, and turmoil began tearing the night apart. Izuku's pulse spiked as he dared to look back. And what he saw made his heart plummet as if he was on a rollercoaster.

Vipers and Yakuza were pouring out from every inch of the Ninth Circle. Their guns and weapons were drawn. Through the wobble of his vision, he caught a glimpse of Tomura and

Zen spilling out with the mob.

And they looked murderous.

Izuku forced his legs to go faster.

They got to the Eighth Circle, and it was pandemonium. Hundreds of intoxicated partygoers were crammed wall to wall. From behind them, the disarray surged closer. Screams yelling out "*get them!*" and "*they killed Chisaki Kai!*" rang out in a brutally high-pitched cry.

Once those words were heard, all heads turned toward them.

They shoved and pushed through the crowd. The entire way, hundreds of people yelled and shouted after them. Several times they had to wrench their arms away from prying hands as they pushed their bodies to accelerate.

Through it all, Izuku followed Shinsou's lead.

They began to make a sharp turn—but then Katsuki abruptly yanked him the opposite way.

Izuku's head whipped around in shock just in time to see Shinsou, Monoma, and Sero swallowed by the suffocating crowd. For a fleeting heartbeat, he caught the glint of his wedding haori on Monoma's shoulders. It sparkled like diamonds, drawing eyes exactly as it was meant to.

Then the pack behind them shifted. The Yakuza and Vipers split—one wave chasing Monoma's group and the other broke off after Izuku and Katsuki. But it wasn't even. Most of their pursuers chased after the shining wedding garb.

Understanding clicked into place. Monoma was his decoy.

Izuku shook his head hard, fighting to snap himself back into reality. The barbarous recollection of Katsuki stabbing Chisaki replayed behind his eyes, intense and bloody. Then it finally hit him. Holy shit. Chisaki Kai was *dead*. He was dead and bleeding on the floor with his neck absolutely brutalized—in front of the whole damn Shie Hassaikai.

Like a hammer, adrenaline came crashing down, burning his veins wide open.

His lungs expanded. His stride lengthened. With a fierce grit of his teeth, he tore his wrist from Katsuki's grip and laced their fingers together instead. He ran. He ran faster and faster until his steps matched Katsuki's perfectly.

Katsuki's head whirled toward him, their eyes locking for an instant.

"Stop right there!" a Yakuza bellowed.

Bullets tore through the air, screeching past his ears. A few seared across Izuku's arms, tearing through the hoodie and burning hot lines into his flesh. He hissed. The sting jolted his mind into razor focus. He glanced back and counted—four Yakuza in black suits. They plowed forward, shoving through the packed crowd.

Then suddenly Katsuki's hand was gone.

In a fluid motion, he shoved Izuku behind him and drew his gun. His teeth were bared as he fired. Two clean shots. Two clean kills. Each bullet drilled straight into the skull. But the last two guards were faster. They lunged at them through the crowd. One leveled a pistol; the other drew a curved blade. The crowd screamed. Bodies scattered in every direction, leaving a wide circle.

Katsuki did a quick draw. He fired once, then twice, then thrice.

Each shot was deafening in the tight space. But the guard with the gun dropped low and the bullets chewed plaster instead. The man sprung up, ramming his shoulder into Katsuki's chest. Both of them staggered into a crush of people.

The second guard came for Izuku. His blade glinted under the orange neon lights.

Izuku ducked the first slash, and the blade whistled past his head. The man struck again in rapid succession, aiming to kill. But Izuku maneuvered fluidly. He twisted, bent, and sidestepped as the sing of steel grazed his ears. Taking the defensive, Izuku moved back. He adjusted in his geta sandals, shifting gears. The guard drew a smaller blade and hurled it dead at him.

Izuku dodged and snapped his bare hands around the knife—catching it midair.

His eyes became feral as pain seared his palms. He threw the blade back, twice the speed.

The Yakuza made a fool's attempt to evade, but couldn't. It sliced open his jugular in one precise cut. A hot spray of blood streaked across Izuku's cheek, layering on top of Chisaki's. The man dropped, clutching at his neck as he fell to the ground.

Izuku barely had time to exhale before Katsuki's fight crashed into him.

The second guard slammed Katsuki into the side of a building, knocking his gun out of his hand. Katsuki snarled and rammed his head into the man's nose. The sickening crack of bone rang out and blood splattered. But the guard only howled and drew his gun up again.

Izuku was there in an instant.

He caught the man by the wrist and torqued his arm backwards at an angle it wasn't meant to bend.

The guard screamed. Katsuki didn't wait—he drew another gun from his holster and pulled the trigger.

He shot the man directly in the mouth, making blood spray everywhere. Izuku let go and the body dropped.

Around them, the crowd scattered further. Countless people trampled over the bodies as if fleeing a fire. Katsuki ran to retrieve his gun off of the ground, his chest rising like he hadn't

missed a breath. Another bullet cut past Izuku's ear, and he flinched. Through the crowd, another wave of guards were coming at full speed.

Katsuki jerked his chin toward the stairs to the Seventh Circle. "We gotta keep going."

They ran again, vanishing into the disarray as the music still thrashed on above the screams. Izuku could hear the shouts of the Yakuza behind them. He could feel the burn in his lungs and the rhythmic thumping of his ankle monitor—

Shit.

His ankle monitor.

Izuku came to a horrified, skidding stop. His head snapped down to see it blinking red, at an extremely fast pace. Much faster than ever before.

"Katsuki!" Izuku screamed.

Katsuki turned and glared at him as if he were crazy for stopping. Izuku quickly ran, caught up, and grabbed his arm. He peered behind them frantically and began searching for another route. In his panic, he found a denser, more chaotic group of people. They were all gathered around some sort of grisly street brawl.

Izuku dove into the crowd. Instantly, curses were hurdled their way.

Katsuki yelled at him too, "Where are we going?! Izuku! *Izuku*!"

But he didn't stop. He wedged them deeper and deeper into the sea of bodies, trying his best to lose the Yakuza tailing them.

When he looked back and couldn't see them, Izuku ducked them into a hidden, discreet alley. He pushed several gawking people out his way, leading with his shoulder as he gripped Katsuki hard. He didn't stop until they were tucked away in a corner, far away from the turbulent commotion.

"Izuku, we have an escape route," Katsuki insisted. "We need to go *that* way—"

"—I have an ankle monitor," Izuku blurted out. "They're still tracking me."

Katsuki looked down. His face went pale. He pressed a finger to his earpiece, breath quickening as his eyes darted through the shadows of the alley.

"We have a problem," Katsuki hissed. "Those sick fucks put an ankle monitor on Izuku. I'll try to find something to break it off with, but they may know you're a decoy."

Through the earpiece, Izuku could faintly hear Monoma's voice.

"Well, they don't seem to know right *now*!" He shouted back. Gunshots rattled off. "They are really trying to kill us over here!"

Izuku looked around too, both searching for something heavy. And when they turned the corner deeper into the darkness, they found a discarded pile of bricks.

Katsuki dropped into a crouch, snatching up the block in one hand as his other clamped firmly around Izuku's ankle, dragging him closer. Izuku bent down in the same breath, steadying the ankle monitor so Katsuki could work.

"Keep it still for me and brace yourself," Katsuki said.

That was all the warning he gave before he hauled back and struck. The brick slammed against the monitor, sending sharp pain up Izuku's leg. He gritted his teeth, refusing to cry out, and forced himself to hold the shackle stable. Katsuki struck again and again. Sparks spat out with every strike, bouncing against the damp alley floor.

Suddenly, the voices at the alley's mouth grew louder.

"Where did they go?!" a rough snarl demanded, close.

Another voice answered, trembling. "Th-They went that way!"

Katsuki's jaw clenched, and Izuku's hands shook. Katsuki raised the brick high and brought it down with a roar. The shackle buckled and a small split cracked down the center at the same time footsteps began moving in their direction. Katsuki struck again. Then again. And again —each blow harder, more desperate than the last.

Then finally, he hauled back and gave one more. This time, angrier.

The metal split straight down the middle, and the monitor fell to the ground in jagged pieces.

Izuku gasped in relief, shaking the numb pain from his ankle. They quickly stood up again, but they weren't given an ounce of breathing room.

"There they are!"

They tore deeper into the alley, the first Yakuza rounding the corner behind them. Gunfire cracked again, and bullets sparked off brick and ricocheted. Izuku flinched when a few tore through his hoodie and kissed his skin. That shallow burn of pain made him move faster.

Together, they weaved a hard left. Then right. Then they pushed their bodies through the winding alleys as the shouts drew closer. Beside him, Katsuki was fumbling with the map device in his palm.

Izuku took one glance and saw the route—and it was the long way.

Izuku seized Katsuki's wrist. Without a word, he yanked him to the left and took the lead.

Izuku had prowled this labyrinth for years, running errands and ferrying Tomura's deals. At this point, he knew the Nine Circles of Hadeus well enough to call them a twisted sort of second home. He pushed himself into high gear. He cut sharp turns. He pivoted hard. He juked around blind corners and leapt over boxes that stacked like broken teeth in the alley.

Ahead, Izuku spotted what he was looking for: a small, discreet doorway draped with black curtains that had violet light spilling from beneath.

He bolted straight for it.

They crashed through the curtain and into the club.

“Hey! You need to pay cover!” The bouncer barked, but was too slow to stop them.

They barreled through the purple haze at top speed. Izuku muttered a breathless apology to a man he knocked flat, while Katsuki hurdled over him without breaking stride.

The club was drenched in smoke and thick with heat. Countless partygoers curled around hookahs and low tables. Blurs of faces turned toward them, startled and irritated—then the sound of gunfire popped through the music, slicing the smoke apart.

The club exploded in chaos.

Izuku ducked low and veered sharply. He dragged Katsuki through the stampede of bodies trying to avoid the rounds the Yakuza carelessly pumped out. The deadly bullets whizzed overhead, cutting through paper lanterns and ripping into the wallpaper. Izuku wove them into the thickest part of the chaotic crowd, smothering their pursuers’ line of sight.

When he looked back and didn’t see them in the mayhem, he rushed towards the back.

With his shoulder, he rammed the side door, flinging it open. They were spat out into the street with dozens of people behind them fleeing the scene.

They looked up, there were the stairs to the Seventh Circle.

“Fucking perfect,” Katsuki complimented. He flashed his feral, lopsided grin Izuku’s way.

They flew up the stairs two steps at a time, racing upward. All up and down the pathway, crowds had gathered, still packed shoulder-to-shoulder. Every single person was pointing and shouting. Izuku caught flashes of people’s expressions as they climbed.

Horror. Delight. Astonishment.

It was obvious what was happening. By now, word likely spread faster than wildfire: Chisaki Kai, slaughtered at his own wedding. And Izuku, his newly wed husband, fleeing the scene hand-in-hand with his murderers. Izuku felt the critical time crunch now. The longer they lingered in Hadeus, the more the jaws closed around them. Izuku’s mind scrambled, trying to get them out quicker.

An idea sparked.

“I know a shortcut,” he panted, glancing at Katsuki as they climbed. “There’s a Shie Hassaikai personnel building on the Seventh Circle—it connects straight to the fourth. We can use it.”

“Any shortcut is a good one,” Katsuki replied hastily.

They reached the top of the stairs, and the street they spilled onto was alive with music and deep indigo neon lights. Revelers were gambling in the middle of the street in a drunken haze. Katsuki and Izuku sprinted toward the shortcut, only to skid to a halt as a fresh wave of Yakuza rounded the bend, blocking their path.

They spun and bolted the opposite way, shoving through startled onlookers.

“How many of these fuckers are there?!” Katsuki snarled.

“Hundreds,” Izuku replied. “They invited all the syndicates families—”

“Great. Just fucking great!”

Izuku risked a glance over his shoulder. His pulse spiked as he counted their hunters—then something happened.

One of the suits staggered mid-stride. He wobbled with a strange, jerking hitch in his gait, and his eyes popped wide. His hands fumbled, dropping his gun, and flew to clutch his stomach. He stopped fully and began heaving desperately—and blood came up in thick, grotesque chunks.

In the blink of an eye, he collapsed, knees buckling like a tumbling house of cards.

Goosebumps raised on Izuku’s arms.

He recognized that man. He’d been at the wedding—and he ate four slices of cake.

Katsuki shot him a confused look, but Izuku didn’t have time to explain. Behind them, the rest of the Yakuza charged forward, hesitation rippling through their stride as they turned to look back at their fallen comrade. They called out after him, urging him to get off the ground.

But the man couldn’t. He began convulsing, coughing up more blood, and crumpled further into the pavement.

Izuku snapped his head forward.

With a thick swallow, he became acutely aware of the anti-venom Ochako gave him. He hadn’t touched it after pocketing it right before the wedding, thinking he didn’t need it. He was ready to die with it in his pants’—but now Katsuki was here because he had somehow defied death. Which meant it was Izuku’s turn to do the same.

But he needed to time it right.

If he took it now, he would start to experience the side effects within five minutes: extreme dizziness, muscle cramps, nausea, and fatigue. He would become practically incapacitated as the expulsion process began—and he needed to fight his way out to the surface. If he couldn’t do that, then he was a dead man anyways.

Izuku glanced at the watch on Katsuki's wrist, eyes fully in tunnel vision.

It was 21:00 exactly.

It was going to be tight, but it was possible—he had until midnight.

He led Katsuki down a side street, past gaudy signs and through a gap between two stalls. They ran until they came across a nondescript metal door, tucked beneath an all black awning.

Izuku glanced over his shoulder, checking to make sure they were ahead of their pursuers. But he couldn't hear any booming footsteps. He prayed they stopped and went back for their fallen man.

Looking ahead, Izuku's fingers flew across the keypad and he entered the six digit code he knew by heart. It was impossible to forget. Chisaki Kai had a habit of standardizing passwords across his personnel. This one was the date he had officially taken the throne of his family's syndicate.

The lock dinged, glowing green, and then the door groaned open. They both hurried in and shut the door behind them. Inside, fluorescent lights buzzed over black painted walls. A narrow stairwell spiraled upward into the dark, hovering over them. Carefully, they surveyed their surroundings and found quiet. They were in the clear for the meantime.

"This way," Izuku whispered, already climbing the stairs.

Katsuki raised his handgun as he followed, eyes sharp. Without looking away from the shadows above, he unbuckled the pistol holstered at his hip and shoved it into Izuku's hand.

"For you," he said. "I fired one round, so you have nine left."

Izuku racked the weapon and forced his slick, blood-stained palms to steady. "We have to go up to the fourth floor."

Katsuki nodded, scanning the dark as they climbed. "How'd you know this place existed?"

"Vipers and the Yakuza have…or *had* a very close relationship," Izuku explained quietly. "Whenever we would do business with them, we'd come down to one of their buildings. They have several personal elevators scattered throughout Hadeus for fast transportation. Mainly because of Chisaki Kai—he didn't like to walk for a long time."

Katsuki rolled his eyes. "Figures."

"The Ninth Circle has a secret master elevator that stops on every floor," Izuku added, almost regretful. "But we're too far from it. This is the best we've got."

"Does that mean they probably used it?"

"Yeah. They likely dispersed across all levels. They're going to try to corner us."

“…Shit.”

They reached the fourth floor and found another keypad. Izuku punched in the code without hesitation, and the lock clicked open with a muted clink and a green light.

Then quietly, a creek. Both their heads snapped up when the sound of footsteps began descending towards them. Without a word, they slipped inside and eased the door shut behind them. When they entered, the room was dark. Through the blackness, Izuku could see it was lined with steel crates and the air smelled faintly of dust.

He craned his head to the back to see the door he was looking for: the exit towards the elevator.

As the footsteps drew closer, Izuku and Katsuki quickly dropped low. They pressed themselves into the shadows behind the nearest pile of crates. Fingers tightening around their triggers, Izuku and Katsuki peered out from the edge.

The door slammed open. Three men entered, but their movements were slow and unconcerned. The radios on their belts crackled, the static hum breaking the silence.

“This is a goddamn nightmare,” one of the men huffed. “If we don’t catch those bastards, the Chisakis will have all our heads for this. C’mon. Let’s head to the Fourth Circle.”

The others grumbled in agreement and began walking towards the door.

Then a burst of white noise cut through the room, followed by a woman’s strained voice.

“Hey. Team forty seven, something’s wrong here in the reception hall.”

“What do you mean?” the first man asked sharply. “Did those fuckers circle back?”

“No,” she replied, uneasy. “It’s…it’s something else. The wedding guests are dropping with really bad stomach cramps and sweating through their clothes. Worse, a few of them already passed out cold—the Governor and his wife included.” Her voice trembled. “We’re trying to drag them up to the surface and get them medical attention, but it’s not looking great.”

“What the hell?” Whispered the second guard. “Do they have food poisoning?”

“Probably the oysters,” the first scoffed, shaking his head. “Knew that shit didn’t look right. Rich assholes and their fancy food. Burgers and fries never killed anybody—”

But before he could finish, the quiet third man groaned. He swayed, clutching his stomach.

“Uh…guys—” His voice bubbled, breaking into a lurch. “I…I don’t feel so good.”

The moment their heads turned, Katsuki flicked his hand in a sharp signal. Izuku nodded, steadying his breath.

Together, they fired off two shots in unison.

Two bodies hit the floor.

The third man jerked his head up, eyes wide. He snapped his rifle up and unleashed a spray of bullets. Sparks exploded against the steel crates, painting the dark room with sporadic bursts of light.

Katsuki and Izuku rose from their cover, guns raised. They wove through the storm of bullets. They ducked low, rolled, and answered with return fire. But the man was nimble—sheer desperation making him move fast. He sprinted across the room in long, quick strides.

Izuku narrowed one eye and squeezed the trigger.

His shot flew straight and clean, tearing through the man's temple.

But the corpse's momentum carried it forward. The hand crashed down on the emergency alarm.

The button lit crimson. An earsplitting klaxon roared to life, shaking the walls and rattling through the building. Both Izuku and Katsuki cursed, and quickly began running for the door. They flung it open and entered an entirely steel corridor hall that was blinking red.

Izuku took the lead, leaning his body forward to sprint until his legs screamed. He turned sharply through the steel halls as the sound of endless storming boots began to charge their way in all directions.

When they turned more corners, the elevator came into view.

Izuku flew to it and slammed his hand on the up button. He pressed it rapidly, sweat beading on his brow. Behind them, the footsteps grew closer, and the shouts of the guards closed in on them like a tightening fist.

The elevator doors finally dinged open, and both of them ran inside.

Suddenly, a voice too close shouted. "I found them! They're in the elevator!"

Bullets soared. Izuku and Katsuki pressed themselves against the sides of the lift and shot out from around the doors.

"All units, head to the first four circles! I have eyes on the culprits—*ah*!" The man collapsed as Katsuki shot out his kneecaps.

The doors slammed shut, and the mechanical groan of the lift started. Without missing a beat, both of them started to recoup. Katsuki tossed ammo to Izuku, who caught it and reloaded in a single, swift motion. With a deep exhale, Izuku slid down the wall.

Katsuki locked eyes with him and said, "When we get to the Fourth Circle, we need to get back on track of the escape route. Aizawa is waiting for us at a designated spot on the surface."

“Okay,” Izuku nodded, anxiety pulling tighter. “You take the lead when we get out the building.”

The lift rattled, shaking with every floor it climbed. Above them, the red light still strobed. Katsuki kept his gun steady, barrel trained on the crack. Izuku pressed himself against the wall, pistol raised.

The ding came.

The doors slid open.

Instantly, four men in dark suits surged in at once. Their rifles fired rapidly as they charged into the elevator without fear. They shot off rounds recklessly as Izuku and Katsuki tried to dodge and take defense. Izuku cursed when one man pinned him to the wall with a rifle.

And then, through the static a voice cut in—loud through Katsuki’s earpiece.

“I got a read on Bakugou!” Denki yelled through the intercom, buzzing with interference. “He made it to the Fourth Circle. Do you have Izuku?!”

Katsuki snarled, ducking under a swing. “Yeah, I got him! We’re sort of fucking busy right now!”

He fired off several shots. One round to a man’s chest and another through his eye. The body spasmed and fell. Next to him, Izuku snapped his palm up, knocking a rifle aside as the trigger went off. The muzzle flashed, exploding inches from his face. The bullet shrieked past his cheek and split into the wall.

“Okay, great,” Denki said. He sounded strained, like he was trying to focus while half-distracted by something else. “You’re a bit off track from the topside exit point. You need to get back east! Team A is still out of my comms reach, but that’s expected—hold tight!”

Another guard swung the butt of his rifle into Katsuki’s ribs.

Katsuki caught it, ripped it free, and slammed the man’s skull against the steel wall so hard it cracked.

The third guard’s pistol came up, too quick. The shots rang out, deafening in the steel box.

Suddenly, pain ripped through Izuku’s arm. His own blood sprayed across the wall as the bullet tore into his muscle. He screamed loudly and his gun slipped from his grip. He swayed, vision flaring white.

“Fuck,” Katsuki growled, cutting his eyes to Izuku as he fought off another man.

Izuku steeled himself, then flung forward. His hand shot out and clamped the shooter’s wrist. He twisted it until the bone crunched, and wrenched the pistol free. In a flash of motion, Izuku squeezed the trigger. The bullet punched through the man’s throat point-blank.

Beside him, Katsuki slammed another guard's head into the elevator's circuit board. Sparks flew as Katsuki drove his knife into the side of the man's skull. He ripped it free, spraying more blood across the elevator walls.

The last guard lunged.

Izuku slammed into him, pinning him to the wall even as the rifle went off again. He winced, ignoring the pain in his arm as he overpowered the guard. In a swift movement, Izuku jammed the barrel beneath the man's chin. He forced the man's finger to pull the trigger. Blood sprayed up and came down on him, staining him further in red.

Silence stretched into the lift. Four corpses. Blood everywhere.

Izuku collapsed to one knee, clamping a hand over the hole in his arm. His head became slightly woozy, and he suddenly felt sick to the stomach.

Katsuki crouched beside him, panting. He tenderly wiped the blood off Izuku's face with his shaking hand.

"You good?" He whispered. "Do we need to bandage you up quickly?"

Izuku shook his head and forced his voice out. "I'll be okay. W-We have to keep going. There's not much time—"

The intercom came to life again. Denki's voice strained over the blurry static. "Bakugou, are you still with me? You need to *move*. A shit ton of signals are heading your way *fast*."

"Yeah, yeah—we're fucking moving!" Katsuki barked.

He reached down and helped Izuku to his feet.

Blood dripped in a steady trail as they ran out of the elevator. Izuku led them, sprinting down the steel corridor. Above them, the alarms howled in their wake. When his stomach turned unpleasantly, the adrenaline in Izuku doubled. The pain in his arm went numb as he ate the sensation and funneled it into his core for drive to push toward.

Denki's voice cut in through the static again. "Holy shit, there's a ton of people heading your way, Bakugou—What the hell? It looks like they turned direction."

"Izuku had a tracker on his ankle," Katsuki explained, clenching his jaw. "The decoy mission probably fell through when they figured that out."

They ran out of the building, and the Fourth Circle unfolded in a wash of golden light.

Gold lanterns glowed overhead while the air was alive with smoke from sizzling food carts. Vendors shouted, gangsters laughed, and strangers clinked glasses. However, whispers rippled beneath the noise. Too many heads were bent over phones, and too many thumbs were tapping frantically.

Word of the wedding was likely pinging from phone to phone now.

Suddenly, the sharp rhythm of boots echoed behind them. Katsuki yanked Izuku into the shadows, pressing him close as the Yakuza guards stormed into the building they had just fled. They froze, every muscle taut, holding their breath as the sound of pursuit thundered past.

Only when the echoes faded did Izuku risk a glance around the corner—the path ahead was clear.

They began moving. Leading the way, Katsuki steered them around the crowd with a predator's precision. They ducked from alley to alley, keeping their faces concealed as they moved through the surging crowd.

Along the way, Izuku peered from around the corners. There, he could sometimes see Yakuza lackeys loitering at the fringes. Their guns were pointed as they barked orders at civilians, demanding any information and directions.

By some miracle, they reached the stairs to the Third Circle unscathed. Izuku's chest tightened when the green-and-blue neon glow came into view. But worse, he saw Yakuza prowling the large staircase, snatching hoodies off of heads.

"There's guards on the stairs," Izuku whispered.

Katsuki rolled his shoulders. "Yeah. Prepared to make another run for it?"

Izuku nodded.

They both took deep breaths and sprinted. They dashed upwards, and in a gush of fierce wind, passed by several guards. All heads snapped towards them, and shortly the shouts came.

"There they are! Get them!"

Both Izuku and Katsuki cursed at the same time and plunged up the steps three at a time. Onlookers pointed and raised their phones to snap photos between taking bites of greasy skewers. As they ran this time, Izuku could feel the twist of nausea in his gut, but he forced his legs faster.

Behind them came the pounding sound of pursuit. Dozens were chasing after them.

When they breached the Third Circle, it cut straight into chaos. A barrier of bodies slammed against them. Strangers yelled, stumbled, and spilled food as they tried to shove through. Gunfire split the air, and one shot whistled past, slicing a line across Izuku's ear.

He hissed, swerving to throw them off.

"Bakugou, you're going *west*!" Denki shouted. "You need to go *east*!"

Katsuki slammed a hand against his earpiece, ducking another spray of bullets.

“We’re trying, but it’s not exactly easy!” Katsuki bit back. “How about routing us somewhere without Yakuza swarming every goddamn corner?”

“Okay, okay!” Denki’s voice rattled with static. “Uhh, on your left, there’s a dead end—but there’s a fire escape. If you climb, you can cut through a building and lose them. That building looks void of any Yakuza activity.”

“Got it,” Katsuki quickly replied.

They tore down the street, then cut left. The alley swallowed them in shadows but its foul scent leaked through the air. The reeking smell of rot and piss slammed into Izuku, nearly making him gag. Along the walls, dumpsters were lined up in crooked rows. But behind them, the mob’s roar was gaining speed. Civilians were shouting louder, giving away their position with pointing fingers.

And then they saw it—the fire escape.

Without hesitation, they both jumped from a dumpster onto the fire escape. The grate rattled and screamed under their force. Behind them, bodies were already filling the alley, not too far behind. They climbed up to the third floor, which had the nearest window. Izuku edged toward it, fingers trembling as he tried to jerk it open.

But it didn’t budge. It was locked.

His stomach sank.

He looked down and could see their pursuers closing in tight. He glanced at Katsuki, who was already staring back with the same grim understanding: if Izuku broke the glass, they’d give themselves away.

Soundlessly, they both slid down onto the platform, carefully crouched with their backs pressed into the wall. Izuku took shallow, quiet breaths, trying his best not to make any sound. Katsuki did the same as they cloaked themselves in the dark shadow, praying not to be seen.

Below them, bodies slithered about, running and then coming to a halt at the same dead end.

Izuku peered through the grate below, and his heart stopped when he saw who it was.

“Are you sure that wasn’t really him that went the other way?” Zen asked in a harsh tone. “I saw the Hoari.”

“I know it wasn’t him because I saw the hair color of the second person,” Tomura hissed. “He was *blonde*.” He whirled on the three other Vipers. “I thought you all said you were absolutely certain Bakugou Katsuki was dead?”

“We—” The Viper cleared their throat. “We were! I swear it, we dug up the grave and opened it exactly like you asked. He was rotting inside, face down drowned in his own blood from the abdomen wound. He even had on the same clothes from that night. There’s no way that wasn’t him.”

“Did you flip it over to be sure?” Ms. Nagant pressed. She walked up to the lower rank Viper and sneered. “Tell me you checked the goddamn face.”

The lower rank Viper hesitantly shook his head. “We didn’t think that was necessary given the smell, clothes and state. It looked exactly like him. It wouldn’t be possible for him to break out, clean up, and get a copy cat corpse that fast with the wounds he had all by himself.”

“You dimwits,” Mr. Compress sighed. “He probably had help.”

Tomura closed the distance in two swift strides and punched the Viper in the face. The sickening crack of bone echoed through the alley and the man crumpled to the ground. Looming over him, Tomura stared down with cold, unflinching disgust.

“It’s possible because Bakugou Katsuki is from the goddamn *gutter*,” Tomura spat. His eyes were dark, and his usual composure was coming undone. “Never underestimate a mutt’s determination to fucking live.”

“How could you be so sloppy?” Zen seethed.

In the dim light, Izuku could see an unnatural amount of sweat on his father’s skin. He remembered then that Zen had eaten three pieces of cake.

He eyed Katsuki’s watch. It was 21:15.

The Viper on the ground nursed his broken face and dropped his head. “I’m sorry, Grand Father—”

“—Sorry isn’t going to cut it!” Zen snapped. The sweat on his forehead increased, becoming shinier. “Do you know how much deep shit we’re in? The Chisakis will kill all of us for this! There will be no merger now that there is no more Kai. And all our clients will pull away once this gets around. No one will hire people associated with the Yakuza Heir’s *murder*. We’re going to be blackballed if we’re not gutted first.”

The vein on the side of his neck popped.

“Izuku has ruined us!” Zen continued. “Absolutely *ruined*! Everything I worked for in the last several decades is gone. Gone! All because of that goddamn *thing*.” He groaned, and then paused. He gritted his teeth and shook his head, like he was fighting off wooziness. “When I get my hands on him, I’m going to strangle him—exactly like I did to his fucking mother.”

His words tangled as something ugly shifted in him. He doubled over, then straightened, and clutched at his midsection. Several wet, hacking sounds rose from him. First a gag, then a cough that turned into a ragged, choking fit. His face drained of color and his lips began to turn blue.

Tomura eyed him wearily, unsure what was going on.

“Are you alright?” Tomura asked cautiously. He walked up to him and placed his hand on his shoulder trying to steady him. “You should take it easy.”

Zen's convulsions slowed into a ragged cough. As he looked up at Tomura, his eyes were glassy, unfocused and red at the rims. For a moment there was only the rasp of air and a sick, metallic smell that began to spill into the alley.

"I'm fine," Zen replied. He brushed off Tomura's hand as his breathing became increasingly labored. "I'm just—" His eyes blinked and slowly lagged. "I-I'm just winded from running and I'm stressed. I have no clue what we're going to do now. It's all *gone*. No fucking marriage means no goddamn merger means no…no—"

He collapsed.

The Vipers swarmed in panic, dropping beside him in a frenzy of useless hands. Mr. Compress cursed viciously while Ms. Nagant fumbled at her purse, grappling for water. Tomura dropped to his knees and caught Zen's shoulders, trying to hold him upright. His fingers trembled, hovering as though terrified of breaking him further.

"One?" Mr. Compress asked, voice taut with alarm. He turned to Tomura. "What's wrong with him? What the hell's happening?"

Tomura glanced up, eyes filled with fear. "I…I don't know."

For once, he looked helpless.

Zen's body convulsed, spine bowing as if something inside of him sunk iron claws into his guts. Froth bubbled at the corners of his mouth, thick and white. The foam mixed with the dark stream of blood that spilled from his nose and leaked from the corner of his eye. His face lost all color, fully waxen and corpse-like, and every breath came out a rattling wheeze.

"Grand Father?" Tomura's voice cracked. His frantic eyes searched Zen's face, his chest, his shaking hands—anywhere for a sign that this wasn't what it looked like. "Just hold on—we're going to get you medical attention."

But Zen couldn't talk.

His organs were shutting down, one by one, collapsing in on themselves. A violent cough wrecked him, spraying clots of blood onto Tomura's sleeves. More came after, thick ropes tearing up from his lungs and choking his throat until it sounded like he was drowning on the inside. His whole body shook as though he was being eaten alive from within, each heave bringing him closer to the grave.

Izuku watched from above, his lip faintly curling despite himself.

Watching the venom settle in was disquieting. There was no dignity in this kind of death, dying of poison in an alley that smelled like shit—but Izuku thought it was fitting for a man like his father. He surveyed silently as Zen floundered in pain, dissolving before their eyes.

At last, Zen's head rolled back. His body sagged into limpness.

His eyes, wide and bloodshot, locked open as though death itself had startled him. They stared upward like glass—fixing, with chilling clarity, directly on Izuku and Katsuki.

Both of them froze.

Zen's eyes twitched, just enough to prove he hadn't gone yet. His body shuddered with dying spasms. And with one final, spite-choked breath, his hand crept upward.

His crooked finger lifted, trembling, and pointed.

Straight at Izuku.

Every Viper's head whipped up.

For a split second, Tomura and Izuku's eyes met. Tomura's expression shifted from ghastly to straight down scathing. His brows furrowed. His lips curled. His chin lowered. And his eyes —his eyes seared with unfiltered, wintry resentment and a look of contempt Izuku had never seen before.

Without hesitation, Izuku hauled his elbow back and broke the window.

Glass shattered everywhere, and he threw his body backwards into the building. The jagged edges cut him as he went flying back into a private room. He scrambled upright amidst the shattered pieces and made a run for his life.

Katsuki was right behind, but so were the Vipers.

They tore through green lit rooms, curtains whipping behind them. They ran past beds where startled patrons screamed and yanked sheets over their naked bodies. The two of them pivoted sharply, spotting a spiral staircase and taking it at full tilt.

Behind them, the two footsteps chasing them were faster than the Yakuza. Heavier. Sharper. Better trained, and their pursuers locked on to them like bullseyes.

The stairwell rattled beneath their sprint, iron steps screeching under every frantic footfall. Izuku risked a glance back—and choked. Mr. Compress and Ms. Nagant were chasing them, faces cold with fury as they closed in like deadly snakes. Mr. Compress twirled a fan of kunais in one hand, and Ms. Nagant leveled her twin pistols.

Both struck at once.

The crack of a bullet tore the air, passing so close to Izuku's ear he felt the heat of it, then the railing beside him burst in sparks. Chips of plaster and rusted metal exploded everywhere.

"Down!" Katsuki shoved Izuku hard, forcing him lower as another round punched into the wall where his head had been.

They barreled down the next flight, the stairwell alive with bodies. Moments before it had been full of flirting and kissing, but now it filled with terrified screams. Izuku's lungs heaved, but adrenaline carried him. His feet pounded out a rhythm of desperation. Another shot rang —he flinched as the concrete beside him spiderwebbed.

Ms. Nagant was methodical. She was herding them down exactly where she wanted.

Katsuki yanked Izuku through a half-open doorway. Bullets shredded the hallway where they'd stood, splinters biting their skin as the rotten wood gave way. They stumbled into a narrow service hall, the walls sweating mildew.

Katsuki's face was a mask of fury. "We need to lose them."

"No," Izuku gasped, dragging him toward the next exit sign glowing faintly red. "We need to *kill* them. They won't stop."

The building was a labyrinth, each hallway choking tighter, and each corner a trap. Above them, Mr. Compress and Ms. Nagant's steps closed in.

The final door loomed ahead. Together, Izuku and Katsuki slammed into it with their shoulders, full speed. The lock gave way, breaking wide open under their momentum. Another gunshot cracked—and the bullet punched a millimeter away from Izuku's head, slicing some of his hair.

They fell into green neon chaos.

The bass hit first, a seismic thrum that vibrated through their bones. Strobe lights slashed the darkness into fragments. An inebriated crowd danced, bodies squeezed together in the fever of a beat that drowned any thought.

Katsuki led Izuku into the tide of bodies, dragging him deeper into the swarm. Izuku's chest heaved, his wide eyes darting in panic as the crowd swallowed them.

Behind, the door slammed open again.

Ms. Nagant stepped through, pistols raised and black dress flaring. She moved with the cool command of a general surveying her battleground. Mr. Compress followed, blades gleaming.

The dancers screamed louder, mistaking the guns for spectacle.

Then Ms. Nagant fired one shot—and the illusion shattered.

Screams shattered through the club as dancers and patrons scattered in panic. Everyone raced toward the exits. Chairs toppled, drinks splashed across the floor, and fear pulsed through the crowd like electricity.

Katsuki didn't hesitate. He shoved Izuku sideways as Mr. Compress lunged onto the dance floor, knives flashing under strobe light.

The two collided in a blur of motion. Katsuki drove forward and Mr. Compress slipped back with an acrobatic grace. The older man spun one blade in his hand before slashing low. Katsuki blocked with his forearm, teeth bared, then swung back with a vicious hook.

Their fight devoured the center of the club, fists and steel clashing in violent rhythm.

Across the room, Ms. Nagant was already raising her pistols. Izuku ducked as the first round tore through a glowing bottle behind the bar, glass exploding into a storm of deadly shards.

He dove behind an overturned table, breath ragged.

Ms. Nagant advanced, every step calculated. She fired again, making the wooden table fracture inches from his face.

“Come out, 217,” she taunted. “Let’s put an end to this now.”

Izuku had a visceral reaction to hearing his number.

He tried to not let it get to him, but that simple call made the tattoo on his collarbone burn to life, reminding him of all the misery he endured.

He refocused his thoughts, and his mind began moving at lightning speed. He knew Ms. Nagant was an expert in both near and distance fighting. But her sharpshooting would lay him out cold if he didn’t close the gap. He needed to level the playing field and get in close.

He bit his tongue and exploded out of his cover, sprinting straight towards her. He raised his gun and returned fire. She dodged swiftly, light on her feet. She backslid, keeping the distance, but Izuku tightened in, sidestepping bullets that clipped him along the way.

Ms. Nagant cursed and tried to reset her range, but Izuku was already too near. He slammed his shoulder into her, knocking her against a column. She hissed and swung a pistol down like a club.

Izuku ducked, drove an elbow into her side pressure point—then, from the corner of his eye, movement—

“Izuku!” Katsuki called from the heat of his own fight. “Behind you!”

A Yakuza thug lunged from the scattering crowd, jumping at Izuku with a katana raised. Izuku twisted, caught the man’s weight, and flipped him over his shoulder. The man hit the ground, spine cracking against the floor. In one fluid motion, Izuku fired his last round point-blank into the man’s skull and tossed the empty gun aside.

Seizing the opening, Nagant raised her weapons—and Izuku reacted quickly. He swiftly maneuvered the sharp bullets grazing his skin and grabbed for the katana.

He spun the sword in his grip, backing towards the bar.

Nagant followed, pistols steady.

“You know,” she chuckled as she slowly approached. “I told One you weren’t going to make it when you were younger. I was hoping you died during The Cull, hell. I even made a *bet* on it.”

Izuku spat out a wad of blood and showed his teeth. “I guess I’m a lot harder to kill than you think.”

She leveled her gun. “We’ll see about that.”

He leapt onto the bar counter as she fired. His feet scattered glass and spilled liquor. The bass thundered under his heels. Nagant climbed onto the opposite end, duo pistols in both hands.

Then they danced.

Steel flashed. Gunshots cracked. The bar exploded in broken bottles as they clashed along its length. Izuku swung the katana in sharp swings, aiming for the kill. Nagant fired between his lunges, bullets grazing him.

She ducked low and swiped at his legs. But Izuku countered, blade singing through the air.

Momentum shifted like tides. He pressed her back. She slipped behind him. She drove him low. He surged up again. A vicious rhythm of predator and prey, each refusing to yield.

Then suddenly, she blocked a downward strike with her pistol—and the katana hit against steel.

A crack split the air. Izuku's eyes widened.

The blade shattered in two.

He stared at the broken hilt in his hand, the rest of the sword lying jagged and ruined on the counter. Ms. Nagant smirked and raised her pistol to finish it—

Izuku dove. He grabbed the other half of the blade from the counter and spun both shards in his hands like twin daggers. The duel devolved into a flurry. Ms. Nagant began firing wildly as Izuku deflected bullets with vicious precision. He closed the distance and violently knocked both guns out of her hands with a kick. She snarled and snatched a knife from her leg holster.

She launched at him.

Izuku caught her wrist, slammed his elbow into her throat, and with a savage twist drove the jagged piece of katana through her temple.

The world went still.

Ms. Nagant's eyes went wide, and blood trickled down from her temple, creating clean crimson streaks. Her body flailed, and the shards of green light reflected off her as if she were another broken piece of glass in the room. Slowly, she crumpled, collapsing lifelessly across the bar.

A savage yell split the air.

Izuku's head snapped up just in time to see Katsuki press the muzzle of his gun against Mr. Compress. The bullet punched through the man's eye socket with a deafening crack. Mr. Compress froze mid-motion. His arms fell uselessly at his sides, and his whole body pitched forward.

He collapsed in the center of the dance floor with a heavy, final thud.

His blood spread in a dark pool beneath the pulse of the strobe lights.

Izuku jumped off the bar—but the moment his feet hit the floor, agony stabbed inside him. He staggered and choked. His hands flew to clutch his midsection as he fell to his knees.

Katsuki was at his side instantly. He crouched low, eyes full of concern. “Izuku? Are you sure you’re alright?”

Izuku waved him off. “W-We have to get to safety, quick. I—”

The words were drowned out by the barrage of boots charging toward them. Both of them jerked their heads toward the door. Promptly, Katsuki yanked Izuku upright and dragged them into a sprint.

They bolted out of the club, the cold air of the Third Circle turning their sweat to ice on their skin. All around them, everyone had their phones raised, shouting, pointing, and reveling in the spectacle of the chase.

Izuku could feel their pursuers closing in, but worse, he could feel in his gut the beginning of a steady gnaw.

Katsuki set a brutal pace up the staircase to the Second Circle, hauling Izuku with him two steps at a time. When they broke onto the next level, their bodies were streaked in neon red and fuchsia lights.

Behind them, the pack still chased.

But something had shifted.

Through his wavering vision, Izuku could tell their pursuers were slower now. Some stumbled. Others clutched their stomachs mid-stride. Then one Viper dropped to her knees in the crowd, gagging before coughing up a flood of blood across the floor.

Izuku paled. He recognized her.

She had eaten two slices of cake.

He glimpsed at the watch on Katsuki’s wrist.

It was 21:30.

He furrowed his brow slightly. Something wasn’t right.

This was sooner than expected.

Horrible realization hit like a gut punch: the venom was working faster than anticipated. Which meant he didn’t have until midnight—he significantly had *less* time.

They cut east, racing back onto the path Denki had mapped for extraction. Katsuki shoved through the sea of bodies, ferocity and urgency boiling inside of him in equal measure.

Denki cracked through the comm in Katsuki's ear, ragged but clear: "Bakugou, good job, you're back on track! Keep going east—then up to the First Circle. Find an elevator, and you're golden!"

"Got it, Pikachu," Katsuki barked, not slowing his stride. "See you soon."

They ran hard, lungs lighting up as if every breath they took was full of smoke. They forced their bodies to move through the exhaustion, moving on pure adrenaline.

In a blur of neon and gunfire, they climbed to the final, First Circle, limbo. Izuku's heart bloomed with hope as they took their final strides to safety. But every step dragged more shadows in their wake. The Yakuza and Vipers multiplied behind them.

His chest tightened when he realized some faces weren't at the wedding at all. They were fresh reinforcements, untouched and ready for battle. Still they ran, clinging to the thread of their escape route.

They kept going—until the street ahead collapsed into a nightmare.

The alleys they were meant to vanish through were already choked with Yakuza and Vipers. The killers swarmed from the shadows, flooding like hornets disturbed from their nest. And behind them came more, wave after wave, an impossible overflow of bodies that sealed every crack and corner.

"Shit," Katsuki wheezed as he made a hard juke away from the rush of bodies.

"Too many," Izuku rasped, eyes darting to look for another way. "There's too many. They know we're heading for the elevators."

Katsuki yelled into the comm. "Denki! Reroute us—*now*!"

They pivoted hard around the corner, but the jaws of Hadeus slammed shut. More guards appeared making another blockade. The trap was tightening.

Denki's voice came in panicked, "Okay it looks like there's another way for you through—"

Suddenly, a muzzle flash cracked from behind. The bullet sliced past Katsuki's temple with a kiss of hot air. It missed him by a hair, but the impact tore through the comm in his ear. The small device went flying and shattered against a brick wall.

Izuku looked back in horror.

"It's fine," Katsuki growled, eyes locked ahead as they continued to run. "I have a tracker. Aizawa is going to have to find us wherever we surface. We just have to find a place to lie low until he comes—which might not be anywhere at this rate."

Izuku's eyes flicked to the bodies hemming them in on all sides.

But then an idea bloomed to life as they passed by a neon sign in the shape of a flower.

“Wait—” Izuku whipped his head to Katsuki. “I know another way out! Follow me.”

They cut down another turn, breaking from the bustling congregation of buildings and gawking spectators.

Izuku drove them deeper, away from the buzzing lights and into a part of Hadeus where color faded. The streets grew narrower and dirtier. The noise condensed into a low hum. Rats scattered at their feet, fleeing from the storm of boots and ricocheting bullets that snapped against the concrete.

Behind them, their relentless pursuers pressed on, a mix of Yakuza and Vipers.

As they continued, the ceiling dipped lower as the chase funneled inward. Soon, the city’s pulse thinned into shadowed tunnels littered with tents sagging against the damp walls. Hollow-eyed squatters watched from the dark as Katsuki and Izuku tore past, splashing through stagnant puddles.

Then suddenly several, violent coughs filled the space.

Izuku glanced back—and his breath caught.

More than half of their pursuers had begun to falter. Vipers and Yakuza alike stumbled into each other like falling dominos. Blood seeped out of their noses, eyes, and mouth. They came to a screeching halt and collapsed to their knees. The tunnels filled with the wet, sickening sounds of vomiting. And soon, the floor slicked with a grotesque slurry of bile and blood.

Izuku’s heart stuttered.

Those were the ones who had eaten one slice.

He glanced at Katsuki’s watch. It was 21:45

The poison worked its fatal magic. A fatal chorus of choking, gagging, and death rattles froze the onlookers in their corners. The unaffected Yakuza stared in bewilderment as their comrades seized in agony on the ground. They knelt down and began shaking shoulders and slapping cheeks. They tried everything to force breath back into the people convulsing on the ground.

But it was useless.

One by one, they all sank into the filth, gasping out their last breath together, swallowed by the dirt and rot of Hadeus. Then soon came a second wave, and the same thing happened. The bodies piled on top of each other, and the pursuit stopped dead in its tracks.

Those left standing gazed around in horror. Hundreds of bodies were piling high.

“What the fuck?” Katsuki whispered, revolted.

Izuku jerked his head forward and pressed on.

“C’mon,” he breathed. “We can’t stop.”

Katsuki shot him a sideways glance, unsettled by how unshaken Izuku seemed. Still, he kept his stride.

The tunnels they ventured into grew tighter with every step. The walls dripped with moisture, and the air was heavy with the faint smell of sewage. In the distance, cries and coughs echoed like ghosts bouncing off the walls. Only when the dying screams behind them were out of earshot, did Izuku allow himself to breathe.

He scanned the narrowing passages with quick, practiced eyes. His pace remained unbroken as his chest burned with the ticking clock inside him. Every twist and every corner he navigated with certainty.

Then finally—there it was.

A ladder loomed out of the dark.

Relief broke through Izuku’s grim mask.

“This way,” he urged.

They rushed forward and climbed quickly. The metal rattled under their hands and feet as they made their way up. At the top, Izuku shoved hard against the manhole. His muscles strained as he gave a loud grunt of effort until the manhole screeched open.

Instantly, a blast of frigid air rushed down. It filled their lungs, jarring them as they hauled themselves to the surface. Izuku emerged first, and Katsuki was right behind him. Then together, they dragged the flower encrusted cover back into place. It fell down with a thunderous slam, sealing the chaos beneath the surface.

Silence.

The alley was utterly quiet, save for the howl of wind funneling between buildings. The shift was so abrupt it was dizzying. Izuku then quickly caught Katsuki’s hand and began tugging him into a steady jog.

They rounded a corner, and Katsuki staggered. He glanced around and blinked rapidly in confusion.

“Wait—” he muttered, eyes wide. “Is this…?”

“The plaza?” Izuku glanced back at him with the faintest smile. “Yeah.”

The two crossed the frost-bitten square together, and Katsuki stared around as if he’d been dropped into another lifetime. Their footsteps echoed in the snow like ghosts as they took the path their younger selves once walked. The angel statue was still gone, and the fountain was shut off for winter.

“How the hell did you know to get us here?” Katsuki whispered in awe.

Izuku smiled sadly.

“I used to sneak through those tunnels to see you, before that place became Hadeus,” he admitted. “I know the way by heart.”

Katsuki caught his eye, and warmth passed between them. Steadily, they laced their fingers together as they jogged. Jointly, they then turned down a familiar, neglected road that held the one place they both knew would be safe.

When they reached their destination, it glowed under the pale blood moon.

The abandoned church sat there, weathered more with chipped wood and broken stained glass windows. It looked like it' been re-boarded up in the last several years, and the rustic cross that used to sit on top was entirely missing now. The building leaned slightly even more, ready to fall apart under the weight of the snow that piled on its pointed roof.

Quietly, Izuku and Katsuki hurried around the back.

There, they found it like they left it: a giant splintering hole in the side, big enough for them to slip through. One at a time, they ducked and crawled inside. Instantly, Izuku felt warmer. The old wooden walls half sheltered them from the deep freeze as the wind whistled with a warning.

He wandered to the center, heart pounding and chest heaving. Izuku lifted his eyes, catching the towering stained-glass window that loomed at the back of the church.

Against all odds, it remained unbroken. Its panes were still intact while the rest of the building crumbled around it. Moonlight poured through the glass, scattering fractured specks of red, blue, and violet across the church. It was still so gorgeous, exactly the way it was all those years ago. Izuku stared at the unforgettable design, a coiled serpent twined around a beautiful red apple.

For a moment the whole image seemed alive.

He then turned his head to Katsuki who was staring as well.

They locked eyes in a moment of silence.

Like a floodgate being opened, safety overflowed inside Izuku. It overtook him as he realized that they had made it out—alive. *Together*.

Every emotion came crashing down at once. Grief. Joy. Disbelief. His shoulders shook with the weight of it all, and his face crumbled. Inside, his heart clenched hard, begging him to return to the person he always called home. He looked Katsuki up and down, still grappling to comprehend that he wasn’t dead after drowning for so long in the darkness of his grief.

Katsuki stared at him back, eyes slowly watering up.

Then, without words, they ran to each other and collided into a fierce embrace.

Izuku choked out a sob as he heard the beating of Katsuki's heart. Its thumping anchored him to reality. It showed him with every pounding pulse that this was real—this was all *real*. Katsuki was alive and he had somehow defied all the odds.

Before he could stop it, a heavy onslaught of tears began pouring out his eyes. He clutched Katsuki harder, fingers shaking as he grasped on to him for dear life. The weight of his emotions shedded off of him, rolling down his shoulders and cheeks as relief so intense it filled his soul to the brim. He sobbed as Katsuki tightened his hold. Izuku tightened too.

They pulled back and Izuku looked up, face wrecked.

Tears carved clear tracks down Katsuki's blood-streaked face. With a trembling smile, Izuku lifted his hand and gently tried to wipe them away.

Beautiful scarlet eyes flicked over Izuku's face, studying every gash and bruise.

But then, Katsuki paused. His faint smile faltered. And then his gaze slipped to the side, as if something unnerving passed through his mind. He fixed Izuku with a dead serious stare.

"What was up with everyone dropping like that?" He asked wearily. "That was lucky for us, but what the hell was that? Is the air down there toxic or something?"

Izuku swallowed hard. His throat tightened as he forced the words out.

"No," he whispered. "I…I laced the wedding cake with a mamushi venom mixture."

Katsuki stared.

Then piece by piece, slow, horrific realization settled in.

"Izuku…" Katsuki rasped, eyes inching wider and wider by the second. He went ghost white in the face. "But you *ate* the wedding cake. I watched you—"

Izuku managed a broken smile, sorrow in every curve of it. And Katsuki's grip tightened as if he could hold him in place against the inevitable.

"No. No. *No*—" Katsuki's voice cracked, frantic, and unraveling. "Fuck, *Izuku*! Wh-Why the hell would you do that—"

Then suddenly, the clock in the church struck 22:00 sharp with a loud, melodic ring.

Izuku's stomach twisted in violent agony.

He gasped and yelled. The sound bounced through the church. Blood splattered his lips as he coughed, and his body began throbbing with an unorthodox amount of searing pain. His knees buckled—and quickly, Katsuki caught him before he hit the ground, hauling him upright in a desperate grip. Petrified, Katsuki's expression broke wide open with panic.

Izuku forced himself to stand, though the world tilted at the edges of his vision

“It’s okay,” he whispered quickly. “I-I have the antidote in my pocket. It’s a triple dose so if I take it now I should be fine.”

Katsuki nodded, nerves on edge as he held Izuku up.

Quickly, and with a huge wave of relief, Izuku dug into his pants’ pocket. He reached his hand down low for the vial—

—and found nothing.

He froze.

A chill punched into his spine.

He hastily switched sides and checked the other pocket. Dread seeped onto his face as he patted down his pants for the vial. But as he did so, he came to the sinking realization it wasn’t there. His pockets were entirely empty.

He froze. Katsuki froze as well, mirroring his ghastly expression. They stared at each other as the direness of the situation settled in.

Izuku glanced at the clock in the background, ticking forward.

“I-I had it,” Izuku stammered, his voice falling apart. “I swear, it was right *here*—”

One footstep changed the whole mood.

Izuku and Katsuki snapped their heads to the entrance.

Standing there, covered in blood was Tomura. His clothes were soaked through with crimson that dripped in slow, obscene drops to the floor. Fly away pieces of hair clung to his forehead in matted chunks, and his eyes—his eyes burned so red they seemed lit from within with rage. The machete in his hand gleamed like bone under the moonlight, its edge blackened with gore.

He held up the small, glass vial labeled ‘*mamushi*’.

“Looking for this?” He seethed.

Chapter End Notes

...welp. *locks doors* thank you so much for reading!! ❤️

Chapter 48: Crescendo

Chapter Summary

> Crescendo (volume indicator) — To increase in volume. Often indicates the peak and climax of a song.

Chapter Notes

> Hello everyone!! :') I hope you enjoy the second part of the climax. I spent a lot of time crying over this chapter. So my apologies upfront for any tears and saddness. It was a very emotional one, and I think it translated 🥹
>
> Enjoy!
>
> **Warnings: I made myself cry by accident**

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 48 — Crescendo

.

.

.

Tick. Tick. Tick.

Izuku couldn't move.

His bones were frozen to the marrow as the winter winds cut into him. Yet somehow the cold couldn't compare to the frigidness of Tomura's stare. His brother's eyes were icier than any storm. And the longer Tomura glared, the more Izuku's skin iced over as if it was frostbitten.

Tick. Tick. Tick.

Katsuki's grip tightened protectively.

Tomura shifted. He swung his bloody machete over his shoulder and tilted his chin up calmly. But his composure was broken. His lip was curled. His cheek twitched. And his eyes were bloodshot, with red veins spiderwebbing across every inch.

Tick. Tick. Tick.

The clock progressed steadily, every second counting down to doom.

Izuku's breath stuttered in his chest, shattering the silence. "H-How did you—"

"Before the wedding," Tomura coldly explained. "I slipped it out of your pocket when I hugged you. And then I just followed the trail of *hundreds* of poisoned corpses and your blood all the way here." He tapped the spot on his arm that mirrored Izuku's gunshot wound. "You really should've wrapped that up."

Izuku's gaze dropped, and there it was—his own betrayal written in red.

Bright droplets of crimson littered the floor, trickling like breadcrumbs. His hand flew to his arm, gripping uselessly over the wound. He suddenly felt small.

Tomura stepped forward.

Katsuki pulled them back.

Tomura dryly scoffed, lips contorting into a cruel sneer.

"You know," he taunted. "I mistook this vial for venom. I thought you were going to shoot this up and kill yourself after the ceremony. Because, did you really think, as the one in charge of looking after you, I wouldn't check your room when I noticed how off you were acting?"

Izuku cautiously eyed the vial. "Tomura—"

"—I saw that goddamn snake," Tomura spat, talking straight over Izuku.

He pushed forward menacingly, and malice eclipsed his eyes with every step he took.

Katsuki and Izuku backed up steadily.

"I thought for certain you had hit rock bottom and that this—" He lifted the vial. "—Was mamushi venom. I saw it in your hand in the hallway. I figured I was stopping you from doing something stupid—*like always*. I even prepared for you to use this on yourself and talked to the Chisakis about putting you on suicide watch. But I see I had it all wrong."

He studied Izuku with disdain.

"I would've never guessed you were plotting to take everyone down *with* you—" Tomura dug into Izuku, the bitter winds howling with his words. "But you did it. They're all dead, you know. The Chisakis. The Governor. Half of the Yakuza and *all* the Vipers. One died in my fucking arms."

He gestured to his clothes, which were drenched in blood.

“If I had known you poisoned him with mamushi venom, I could have saved him with the antidote. But instead, I was left confused at what the fuck was happening. He coughed up so much damn fluid I don’t think he had any left when he finally went.”

Izuku’s stomach knotted, twisting tighter with every breath.

“No response?” Tomura huffed a dry, unsettling laugh. “Of course not. You don’t care. You only care about him. And because of your sickly infatuation, you have, in one fell swoop, destroyed our entire lives—and betrayed me more than I could have ever imagined.”

“I didn’t want it to come to this,” Izuku countered, finding his voice. “If you had just let me go, none of this would have happened.”

“You’re so fucking stupid, Izuku,” Tomura exasperated as if he was talking to a child. “As long as you were attached to someone who slaughtered *five* members of the goddamn Chisaki family, you would’ve never gotten far.”

Izuku opened his mouth to retort—but instead he coughed. A small bit of blood came up, making both his and Katsuki’s eyes widen.

Tomura tilted his head, eyes narrowing in on the red drip coming from Izuku’s lips.

He held up the vial. “You need this soon, don’t you?”

“Just give him the fucking antidote,” Katsuki snapped. “I know you don’t want to see him die.”

“You have no idea what I want,” Tomura venomously whispered. His wintry gaze sliced to Katsuki, filled with a terrifying amount of hostility. “Especially now that I know my own brother tried to *kill* me.”

Izuku stiffened.

Tomura’s eyes darkened with unfiltered animosity.

“It was the cake, right?” Tomura asked. “Because I was the only Viper who didn’t eat it.” Another dry laugh. “Ironic, isn’t it? To think, simply not liking matcha is what spared me from your goddamn *treachery*. All I’ve done to keep you alive—and that is how you were ready to repay me.”

Tomura stepped forward into the stain glass’ glow. Shards of red and violet littered across his pale skin, painting him like some desecrated saint.

Izuku and Katsuki edged back.

But Izuku’s legs rattled. His adrenaline was flooding what strength he had left. Something was building. He could feel the intense pressure weighing down, and he knew when it broke loose it would be nothing short of monstrous.

Tomura's face distorted, snapping under the weight of his indignation. His features folded as hurt tore through, only to be carved over a heartbeat later by contempt.

"You have taken everything I have worked for," Tomura accused, voice fraying. "Just to be with *him*."

"No," Izuku said, tone steadier than he felt. "I did what I did because this has to *stop*, Tomura. The children, the poison, the endless killings—the cycle had to be broken."

"Broken?" Tomura parroted unkindly. "I would gladly kill a hundred children again if that's what it took, Izuku. I clawed my way up that ladder of corpses so we wouldn't be devoured at the bottom of it. And I will never apologize for that."

"But now it's gone," Izuku shot back. "M-Maybe now…you don't have to do that. You can live your life without all the death."

"You still don't get it. I think the cycle is *good*. Humans are not kind creatures made of fucking love or whatever else you have convinced yourself. Humans *deserve* death. Every single person. I put myself at the top for two reasons: survival, but the other was because I enjoy killing. I was only envious of Nine because he got to *determine* who to kill."

Izuku stared in horror.

Tomura truly believed everything they were taught.

"And if I get the chance, I will rebuild that cycle," Tomura promised viciously. "Do you think I was assisting One for the hell of it? No. I wanted to help him *perfect* it."

Izuku's eyes flicked back and forth between Tomura, the clock and the vial.

Tick. Tick. Tick.

"And now, I realize my mistakes," Tomura continued. "Every time I let you keep a shred of naivety—I should have crushed it. But my worst mistake was not killing this mutt the moment I found he had his claws in you."

His glare plunged subzero, colder than the lowest circle of hell. All the grief and fury he was feeling tangled together in his expression, as if hating Katsuki was the only way he could keep from breaking apart.

With a sharp inhale, Tomura fortified himself. His composure snapped back into place like a lock sealing shut.

"Izuku. If you want this anti-venom—he's going to have to die," Tomura declared with finality. "Because there's not a goddamn chance in hell I'm letting you go with him after what you've done."

"And then what, Tomura?" Izuku hissed, readying himself.

“And then I figure it out, like I always do. I’ll hand his head over to the Yakuza for murdering Chisaki as penance, and then you—maybe I’ll carve up that face of yours now that it’s no use to me anymore. Or maybe—maybe I’ll *sell* you again to the highest fucking bidder so we can get enough leverage to start over.”

Katsuki gritted his teeth and yanked Izuku behind him. “None of those things are going to happen you sick bastard.”

“Make your choice Izuku,” Tomura said, ignoring Katsuki. “The antidote or him.”

“You know I’m not going to make that decision,” Izuku replied.

Tomura pocketed the anti-venom into his pants. With a deadly, steady hand, he reached back and grabbed his second machete from its holster. It gleamed under the moonlight, and all of Izuku’s instincts snapped into place.

Katsuki straightened and grabbed his gun.

“If this is the way you want it, then fine,” Tomura spat. “I’ll make the right choice for you. Like I always do.”

Tomura struck—so fast he was invisible until impact.

Izuku barely registered the blur before he was hurled sideways, ribs screaming as he hit the ground. Katsuki tried to swiftly backslide—but was too slow. Tomura swung his machetes down in two lethal arcs, slicing straight into Katsuki’s arm.

“Shit!” Katsuki screamed, blood streaming hot down his sleeve.

He stepped back and quickly drew his gun. But Tomura was on him, far faster than Katsuki ever could be.

Izuku choked, stomach cramping as the poison stirred. When his focus re-stabilized, his heart sank. Tomura and Katsuki were clashing in a vicious struggle—and Tomura was going all out. He was aiming to kill Katsuki for real this time.

Izuku forced himself upright and sprinted forward. He tried to go low, and aim for Tomura’s legs—but Tomura’s reflexes were sharp. His brother pivoted, and his knee drove into Izuku’s ribs like a battering ram, the crack audible. Air left Izuku in a broken gasp, blood splattering from his lips as he skidded across the ground.

Katsuki raised his gun and took the shot—but Tomura bent sharply. The bullet grazed past his shoulder, and in an instant he swung at Katsuki again. But Katsuki was ready this time and dodged by a thin hair.

“Come on, bastard,” Katsuki growled, teeth showing. “Try me!”

Tomura didn’t respond. Instead, he devoured the distance, machetes glowing like two streaks of moonlight.

The two titans collided head-on, matched in strength. Katsuki caught each strike with crossed pistols, every clash sent a numbing jolt up his arms, but Tomura's speed didn't break—it built. In response, Katsuki fired point-blank, trying to blow Tomura's head straight off. The recoil cracked like thunder between them as they stormed around each other in a blizzard of steel and bullets.

In the midst, Izuku was struggling to stand up. Every time he did, he fell. The poison was gripping his ankles, dragging him further into the grave with every second that slipped away. He watched with terror twisting inside him as the two kept going.

For a breath, Katsuki held the advantage. He whipped the pistol across Tomura's jaw, once, twice and then thrice. The sickening crunch reverberated through the room.

"Die already!" Katsuki yelled, each blow punctuated with unbridled rage.

But Tomura absorbed it, his head snapped back only to return with that terrible, unflinching snarl—as if pain didn't affect him at all.

Blood ran from his split lip and he sneered, "Is that all?"

Tomura's elbow whipped up into Katsuki's jaw, rattling his skull. A blink later, a brutal head butt split the space between them. The sound of bone smashing against bone cracked loudly, and Katsuki violently stumbled.

Tomura jeered, "Just as weak as your addict of a mother."

Izuku saw Katsuki stagger, dazed and open. And then his brother took a stance—to kill.

Adrenaline bolted past the poison inside of Izuku. He forced his battered body to move, wooden shoes pounding across the floor. He stopped the next machete swing in time by slamming his shoulder into Tomura's side.

For the first time, Tomura faltered. Izuku had matched his speed.

But speed alone wasn't enough. His brother recouped in record time and dropped his elbow straight into Izuku's gut. But this round, Izuku steeled himself. He braced his body and absorbed the hit—exactly how Tomura taught him too.

In those seconds, Katsuki came back to himself, teeth bared.

The tides turned, and it was two against one.

Izuku barreled into the storm, forcing his body to comply even as his lungs disagreed. He spun in with a flurry of aerial kicks. Each one was sharp and merciless.

Tomura met him with ease. He ducked low, letting each strike whistle past by the breadth of a hair. And his arms flowed up to block while his face remained entirely unfazed. He shifted with ghostlike precision, all while managing to hit Katsuki with relentless blows even as he warded off Izuku.

Katsuki did his best to block and returned fire. With every opening Izuku could give him, he landed a thunderclap like blow behind Izuku's lightning speed.

In perfect unison, they matched Tomura's inhuman strength and speed. But Izuku could see it in Katsuki's face, he'd never seen anyone fight like this before. Tomura was the top Viper for a reason—and Izuku knew they weren't going to be enough to take him down.

For a moment, his eyes slid to the side. His heart crashed against his ribs as he looked at the clock.

Tick. Tick. Tick.

Quickly, desperation took a hold of him. They needed to knock Tomura out. *Now*. He feinted low, pivoted high, and finally landed a clean blow—a kick that cracked against Tomura's jaw with a snap like breaking wood. Tomura faltered a single step, teeth clenched.

For a heartbeat, Izuku's chest filled with hope.

Then Tomura's hand shot out with bone-snapping speed. He seized Izuku's next kick mid-spin, stealing the momentum from him in an instant. With one brutal twist, Tomura hurled him across the room. Izuku's body slammed into a wooden pew with a nauseating crack. The bench split apart under the force, and he crumpled into the wreckage, gasping as fire ripped through his body.

Blood spattered from his lips and his stomach heaved. He gasped with one arm clutching himself as though he could hold his insides together.

Katsuki's jaw clenched at the sight, but there was no time to breathe. The pressure on him thickened, and Tomura's darkness blotted out the world. A fist came in like a sledgehammer, striking Katsuki square in the chest. The impact pushed him back. His boots skidded against the floor and air ripped from his lungs.

"The longer you fight me, the faster he dies," Tomura said coldly. "You might as well let me cut your goddamn throat now."

"Shut up!" Katsuki screamed. "Just shut the hell up already!"

He met Tomura head-on with no hesitation. The world narrowed to the brutal rhythm of gunfire yet again as Izuku struggled to lift himself back into battle. He wheezed and a wave of nausea brought him down.

More red spilled from his lips—more than before.

From the wooden wreckage, Izuku watched yet again as the church rang with the deafening thunder of countless gunshots.

Bullets tore everywhere. They splintered the wood as they tore through walls and shattered pews. Muzzle flashes lit the hollow sanctuary in quick, violent bursts. Katsuki burned through all his magazines in seconds, and when the final click echoed, silence pressed in like a suffocating hand.

Neither waited.

Katsuki ran forward, knife flashing into his grip as he drove in. He fought like a tsunami unleashed, raw strength and sharpened brutality colliding with Tomura's frightening ruthlessness.

An opening flared—small, fleeting, but enough. Katsuki seized it. His knife tore across Tomura's ribs, the edge sliced deep, and his fists followed with bone-cracking force. The sound of Tomura's ribs snapping echoed, a thunderous crack that filled Katsuki's chest with savage satisfaction.

But Tomura didn't flinch—he struck back.

A machete swung up in a merciless swing, the blade hissing past Katsuki's guard. It carved across his temple, shallow but searing, and blood sprayed warm down Katsuki's face.

Snarling, Katsuki shifted. His eyes cut sharp to Tomura's pocket—and Izuku followed the line of vision.

There, the vial glinted faintly beneath the moonlight.

Izuku's heart stopped. Katsuki's face contorted, and he sprung with a new purpose.

He wove past Tomura's strikes, but only barely. He took hit after hit until his body was covered in gashes. Soon, his movements turned deliberate, each strike barreling towards Tomura's body but angled as if he was circling him. Tomura kept up, but his face twisted in confusion when it became clear Katsuki was no longer aiming to kill.

When he realized what Katsuki was doing, it was a split second late. Katsuki rounded him—and got a full opening for Tomura's pocket.

Quickly, Katsuki's hand shot out. His fingers closed around the vial and snatched it.

Izuku's chest surged with wild hope.

Katsuki tore away, sprinting toward him, blood streaking his face but eyes locked on Izuku. The vial was in his hand, and for the first time Izuku felt the weight lifting. He told his body to move and suddenly he was on his feet, running towards Katsuki.

But then Tomura was there.

He appeared in Katsuki's path like smoke solidifying into flesh, faster than sight and crueler than gravity. He unleashed a cruel, precise kick, and his boot slammed into Katsuki's chest, sending him flying backwards.

The vial flew.

It spun in the air, slow and helpless. The entire world narrowed to that fragile fall of glass.

Izuku ran and reached for it. His hand clawed out though he was too far. Katsuki rebalanced quickly. He sprinted and reached out, bloodied fingers stretching. But Tomura moved like he owned the moment. His hand snapped up with inhuman grace.

The vial fell into his fist, as if inevitable.

Izuku's stomach dropped into a pit of ice.

Katsuki, with blood running into his eye, ran back for the vial with a roar. Izuku did as well. They met gazes, and understanding passed between them without words: get the vial.

They began a full scale assault.

Where Izuku hit quickly and precisely, Katsuki was all brute force, each blow they landed inched Tomura step by step towards the altar. Izuku became Katsuki's shadow, darting in and out. His kicks landed with error-free precision as he blocked the blows Katsuki couldn't. And Katsuki became his echo, landing strikes of strength Izuku wasn't able to. Together, they pressured Tomura. Fully in sync, like two sides of the same coin.

But between them, the vial was chaos.

It slipped from Tomura's fist in the hurricane, glass glinting under the pale light.

Izuku dove, hitting Tomura back as his free hand closed around it. But then Tomura's boot smashed into his stomach. The vial was torn from his grasp before he could retreat. Then Katsuki threw himself recklessly. He grappled the vial from Tomura's hand as their blades locked. But Tomura twisted, elbow breaking against Katsuki's jaw, snatching it back.

It became a pendulum of fate, swaying between them.

To Katsuki. Then to Izuku. Then to Tomura.

The glass flashed in the rapid exchange of fists, blades, and kicks. Izuku struck, Katsuki sliced, and Tomura moved like the epitome of death itself.

The vial slipped, caught, slipped again—until Katsuki finally ripped it free with a savage punch that sent Tomura backwards.

But Tomura countered. In a blur, his machetes raised to carve straight through Katsuki.

But Izuku matched his speed.

He threw himself forward, body screaming in protest. He twisted in mid-air with every ounce of strength left in him. His shoe smashed into Tomura's wrist at the perfect angle—and one of the machetes flew free. It spun and it buried itself deep into the wall with a splintering crack.

Izuku hit the ground hard. He rolled, pain lancing through his ribs, but he didn't stop. He scrambled up and his fingers seized the hilt of the machete. He ripped it free in a shower of dust and plaster.

With the weapon in his hands, he surged back in.

The church rang with the clash of blades as Izuku countered Tomura in a flurry. His strikes were too fast to follow, each slash darting like electricity.

However, his brother guessed his every move. He countered Izuku with sheer strength, every counterblow heavier than the one before it, but Izuku absorbed it. He clenched his blood soaked teeth as he pushed himself through it, using his nimbleness to keep him alive.

Katsuki darted forward, fist raised to cover him. But Izuku's head whipped around. His eyes locked onto Katsuki's—wild, desperate, and burning.

"*Run*!" he yelled. His voice cracked, but the command boomed. "Take the vial and run! I'll catch up with you!"

Katsuki froze for the span of an inhale, and Izuku knew every instinct of his was screaming not to leave. But then he saw the plan click in Katsuki's face. They needed to outrun and confuse Tomura. If they could find each other before Tomura did, then Izuku had a chance to drink the antidote. Even if only for a second—it would be the small chance they needed.

Katsuki clenched his teeth and bolted.

Tomura tried to follow, but Izuku was on him. He leveraged his speed, getting up every time Tomura knocked him down. He tackled his brother to the ground, and together they went skidding across the floor, streaking it red with blood.

Tomura shoved him off and they began to clash again, machete against machete. Izuku met Tomura's charge head-on. Every strike hurt his bones, but he refused to yield.

"This is foolish," Tomura snarled, his blade caught Izuku's mid-swing and twisted it aside. He shoved Izuku back, voice low and venomous. "Why are you choosing him, when everything I did, I did for you—"

"—No," Izuku hissed, forcing himself upright again, blood slicking his face. He swung again, fast and sharp, forcing Tomura to parry. "Everything you did was what was best for *you*! Your interests were the top priority, every time. I was an afterthought!"

Tomura slammed a kick into Izuku's chest, sending him stumbling. "You have no idea what you're talking about—"

"—Yes I do!" Izuku screamed, voice breaking as he slashed upward, grazing Tomura's jaw. "Everything you've ever done has been with you in mind first! It was all for you! You've deluded yourself into thinking you could make me happy too. But you've never put me first. Your thirst for power always came before me—"

Tomura's fist crashed into his cheek, snapping his head sideways.

"You only think that because you have no idea everything I've done for you," Tomura growled, following with a relentless kick that threw Izuku into another pew. He stalked

forward, machete raised. “I’ve always made sure to take into account your best interest alongside mine.”

Izuku stubbornly got back on his feet, blade trembling in his hands.

“You think this is my best interest?” His voice cracked. “You thought making me watch someone I love die was for my own good? And then *selling* me off to the Yakuza?!”

“Yes,” Tomura replied coldly. “Because we lived in a world where pain wasn’t an option, Izuku. We could only control where we were in the food chain, and I spent our entire lives making decisions so we didn’t have to be the ones getting punched down on.”

He pivoted and slashed low. Izuku barely twisted clear. The blade zinged past his ribs, a strand of his green hair severed in the moonlight. Tomura’s sneer widened.

“You punch down on me all the time, Tomura,” Izuku hissed.

Tomura’s eyes flashed. “It’s different when I do it.”

“So it’s okay that I’m getting hurt as long as you’re the one to do it?!” Izuku screamed.

“Yes!” Tomura yelled. “Because I know where my limits are. I would *never* kill you, Izuku. But I can’t guarantee that with others!”

He began a relentless charge. Izuku tried to block, but it was nearly hopeless. His brother was moving faster than him now, landing a fury of punches and kicks that knocked Izuku off balance.

“Like most children, you do not know what is best for you,” Tomura said, anger growing. He began pummeling Izuku backwards with every punch. “And that’s the paradox, isn’t it? Children always think they know better than the people raising them. But the truth is—we shelter you from so fucking much.”

The blunt end of Tomura’s machete cracked into Izuku’s temple, making stars explode across his vision. He reeled, and Tomura’s other fist crashed into his stomach, folding him in half.

“And given our situation,” Tomura hissed, driving his knee into Izuku’s jaw. “I’m sorry I couldn’t be the soft brother you daydreamed about—but I still did a damn good job. I sheltered you from so goddamn much.”

Izuku crashed to the floor, coughing blood. But Tomura wasn’t finished. He grabbed Izuku by the collar, yanking him up.

“You have no idea the type of torture that went on in that basement your whole goddamn life—and you still don’t. And that’s because of *me*.”

His fist slammed into Izuku’s gut again.

Izuku gagged, blood spilling from his lips, eyes wide in shock.

“You have no idea why my goddamn face looks the way it does,” Tomura snarled, roundhouse kicking him so hard Izuku smashed against the wall, the crack of bone echoing. “Instead, you got to live in the fucking penthouse because of me. You got the lightest punishments in our books, because of me. And you were allowed to live in your romantic fantasy world because *I* decapitated the person who would’ve killed you for such a thing!”

Izuku slid down the wall, leaving a smear of blood, clutching his ribs as he wheezed.

Tomura yanked him up again, one-handed, by the collar into the air.

Izuku choked as his feet dangled.

“And if you didn’t ruin it—you would have married into the most powerful family on this half of the globe, and you would have never lifted a gun to kill ever again if you didn’t want to!” Tomura bellowed. “All because of *me*!”

“Tomura…” Izuku croaked. His body dangled like a broken marionette and his eyes brimmed with tears. “Why can’t you see that everything you did, hurt me?”

“Because even though it hurt,” Tomura answered flatly. “It doesn’t mean it wasn’t for the best.”

With a yell, he hurled Izuku across the church. Izuku’s body hit the wall so hard the stained glass above him shattered, raining shards of crimson and blue across his broken frame.

“Now stay down,” Tomura threatened, icy glare digging into him. “If you pass out, you’re not going to be able to drink the damn antidote.”

He dragged the flat of his blade across his sleeve, refreshing it for new blood. Without another look, he turned and stalked deeper into the church in search of Katsuki.

Izuku’s cheek pressed against the cold floor, jagged shards of stained glass biting into his skin. His whole body quaked as he watched Tomura disappear into the shadows. He tried to move, but his limbs wouldn’t obey. Every breath that spilled out of him was ragged and wet —exactly like the other poisoned individuals.

He pushed against the floor, arms shaking violently, but they gave out under him. The poison was sinking deeper into his flesh, and stealing his strength piece by piece.

His vision swarmed with black blotches, and the edges of his world shrank inward. Flickers of fractured light smeared into the glow of the blood moon, and the building around him collapsed into a blur.

But through that blur, he caught movement. He saw Tomura circle back, pacing the church like an apex predator who had no equal.

“No—” Izuku rasped, the word tearing out of him. “Y-You’re not going to take him from me again.”

Izuku clawed at the ground, smearing blood across the broken glass as he willed his body to move. His chest convulsed with coughs, each one spattering crimson onto the floor, but still he dragged himself on his feet. His knees buckled and his lungs screamed—yet he dashed forward anyway. Because if he stopped now, Katsuki would be gone.

And Izuku couldn't lose him again.

When Tomura vanished towards the basement stairs, Izuku felt another burst of energy. He gritted his teeth, and forced his spine straight. With every ounce of will left in him, he grabbed the forgotten machete and tumbled into a sprint.

The steps to the basement opened before him. He stumbled down, breathing hard as the darkness swallowed him whole. As he descended, the basement reeked of damp earth and old mildew. The space was nearly pitch black and lined with thick pillars that jutted up.

Shadows bled across the walls, swelling until they seemed alive. Izuku's vision swam. The poison began to warp everything, like some twisted house of mirrors. Shapes coalesced in the dark, and the shadows transmuted into the outlines of people long gone. They all whispered and reached for him.

"Come out, Bakugou," Tomura's voice slithered around, echoing from everywhere and nowhere at once. "You might as well surrender. Drawing this out is pointless."

The darkness twisted under Izuku's eyes, outlines of figures flickered between the pillars. Faces from the grave birthed out the blackness. One leaned close, and its hand, long and skeletal, pointed.

It was Hiryu, trying to lead him.

"You think you can protect him?" Tomura hissed, voice sinking in like noxious gas. "You couldn't even protect your own damn mother."

Izuku tripped, and his world tilted. Mitsuki's ghost stood among the shadows now. She raised her arm and pointed further along the way. He followed, half-blinded and chasing after illusions as the world twisted around him.

Tomura's voice sharpened, closer now. "If this continues, he'll die choking on his blood. And all that strength of yours won't be able to help."

Suddenly, a hand seized his shoulder.

Izuku flinched and braced himself—until he turned and saw Katsuki. Relief poured through Izuku's chest, burning hotter than the venom. He was real, alive, and had his finger pressed to his lips in a soft hush. The antidote gleamed faintly in his other hand.

Quickly, Katsuki moved to uncap the vial—

—and the shadows attacked.

Tomura erupted from the dark, sheering through the air like a blade through silk. He slammed Izuku back against a pillar while his other arm swung for Katsuki.

Izuku reeled sideways, hitting the floor, and in the blur he caught a burst of motion—two bodies colliding at a velocity that cracked the air like whips. Steel flashed, fists broke against flesh, and in the darkness Katsuki and Tomura clashed yet again.

Katsuki was holding his own. More than that—he was winning. He adapted to be quicker than Izuku had ever seen him, weaving between Tomura's machete slashes, forcing him to overreach. Every strike Katsuki threw landed heavier and surer. His strength forced Tomura to go on the defensive.

Izuku's heart seized with pride and fear in equal measure.

Then Tomura caught his footing again.

He landed four brutal punches into Katsuki's body, making him topple over.

Izuku's legs moved before his mind did. He hurled himself forward, tackling Tomura by the legs. The collision ripped through his ribs and made his vision burst with white spots. But he held on, dragging Tomura down onto the stone floor. The impact made agony scream into his bones, but he didn't let go.

"Go!" Izuku roared, blood spraying with the shout. "G-Get to the second floor!"

Katsuki took the opening. He bolted up the stairs two at a time, already yelling back, "Head for the nook! He won't know where it is!"

Izuku's pulse surged at the word. His eyes widened when he realized that was their advantage. He stumbled upright, forcing his leaden legs to follow. Pushing through the haze of pain, he sprinted up the stairs.

He dashed up them three at a time, nearly reaching the top—

But before he could clear the last step, cold fingers clamped around his ankle. Izuku slipped, chin hitting the stairs with a brutal thud. He whipped his head, and there Tomura was. He was covered in blood and more hair had fallen out of his bun. His face twisted in a callous sneer.

"You never fucking listen," Tomura hissed.

Izuku screamed out as he was flung down the stairs with unbridled strength. He went flying, the world spinning as he tumbled. When he hit the bottom, his chest hit hard against the cold concrete.

He gasped, breathing becoming ragged as his vision went in and out.

Tomura darted up into the darkness after Katsuki, leaving Izuku sprawled on the ground below, gasping and broken.

He turned on his side and coughed up more blood. He hated how he could hear Katsuki's and Tomura's feet above. But worse, he hated that he could hear a clock down here.

Tick. Tick. Tick.

He heaved himself up, gripping the machete with his twitching fingers. With another push, he clawed his way back up the stairs, each step wearing his muscles down.

Izuku emerged into the chapel again, lungs pulling sharply with every breath. He turned his head, and there they were—Katsuki and Tomura. They were at the altar, locked in depraved combat beneath the serpent-and-apple stained glass window. Its colors washed over them in a distorted kaleidoscope, bathing their blood covered bodies in red and green.

"I'm going to enjoy killing you, properly this time," Tomura spat as his machete crashed against Katsuki's knife. "You have been nothing but a goddamn pest. Everything that has gone wrong with my brother always ties back to you."

Izuku's eyes widened as Tomura hauled his machete back, readying the next, brutal swing.

He took the same stance he had with Nine.

"Kacchan!" Izuku rasped, his voice cracked.

But before Katsuki could hear his warning, Tomura struck.

A merciless blur of punches and kicks hit Katsuki's core. One, three, five, then finally a blow so inhumanly strong crashed into Katsuki's chest. The sound was awful, like all his bones shattered on impact. Katsuki flew backwards and slammed into a row of tall iron candlesticks. The metal shrieked as they toppled and scattered across the floor right as Katsuki's skull hit against the stone wall.

Blood trickled down. His eyes rolled back and then his head lulled. And in a horrible moment, his whole body went slack, dropping into a cold heap.

"*No*!" Izuku screamed. He stumbled forward, heart tripling in speed.

The small glass vial slipped from Katsuki's hand and rolled across the floor. Tomura's eyes followed it. He picked it up and curled his pale fingers around the antidote. Then he turned back. And raised the machete.

Izuku's heart stopped. Tomura's shadow fell across Katsuki's unconscious form as he lifted the blade high, its edge aimed clean for the neck.

Something inside Izuku tore open.

His body exploded. With one last, impossible surge, he threw himself forward. Every ounce of strength, fury, and love drove him into Tomura's path.

The machete swung down—

And Izuku was there.

His blade caught Tomura's in midair, steel shrieking on steel as sparks spat out between them. The collision rang through the church like a bell.

Tomura staggered half a step off balance. Izuku hit the ground moving, fist driving deep into Tomura's ribs. A sharp crack split the air. Tomura doubled over with a gasp.

Izuku didn't stop. He couldn't.

Bone crunched under his knuckles as he slapped another punch into Tomura's jaw, popping his head to the side. Izuku struck again and again, driving him backwards away from Katsuki and towards the altar stairs.

His vision blurred with tears. He poured everything he had into every strike to keep Katsuki safe.

But Tomura rebounded. His head whipped back, eyes blazing, and he blocked the next blows with frightening precision. He dodged, sidestepped, countered and moved like a mirror of Izuku—beat for beat.

Izuku matched him back. Every pivot, every slash, every strike was the same brutal rhythm Tomura had drilled into him for years. He heard his brother's voice inside his skull, whispering old commands—faster, harder, cleaner—and he obeyed without thinking.

In that instant they were equals: two forces perfectly opposed, their blades like lines drawn across a battlefield.

And balanced on that thin, trembling line between them was Katsuki's life.

Izuku felt Tomura's frustration grow into rage. With each blocked strike, with each dodged punch, the resentment inside Tomura grew. It became a black mass rearing like a second head from his body. Its eyes glowed a sickly, deathlike red, searing through Izuku.

"The longer you fight me, the closer to death you get," Tomura hissed. His eyes flicked to the clock, and for a moment his anxiety showed through. "Are you really willing to put your life at risk for him? Is he really worth all this?!"

"Yes!" Izuku's voice cracked. "I'll fight for him every single time—and that will never change!"

He swung high, aiming for Tomura's temple to knock him out. But the blade missed by a hair. Tomura ducked low, and the machete caught something else. With a sharp snap, it cut the red string holding Tomura's hair.

It floated to the ground between them, severed.

His brother's long, bone white hair spilled loose over his shoulders. And in that moment something shifted. His nostrils flared, his eyes darkened, and his body adjusted. Every strike

now came sharper, and far more lethal. Izuku felt it instantly. The air changed. It turned cold enough to raise goosebumps along his arms.

A swing carved too close to his neck for the first time, forcing him to stagger back, and the truth sank in.

Tomura was going for the kill.

His brother's machete lashed again and again, each strike more vicious than the last. It beat Izuku back as he made terrible, desperate blocks.

For the first time in his life, Izuku recognized he was on the other end of Tomura's lethality—the razor sharp edge his brother had always kept sheathed for him. Now it cut straight for his throat, his chest, and his vital organs. Every near-miss whispered how close he was to being cut open.

"You love him so damn much?" Tomura spat, eyes wild and composure gone. "Then die for him! Hand in fucking hand!"

He blurred forward, faster than Izuku could track. By the time Izuku caught the movement, it was already too late to block.

The machete angled straight for his heart.

Time slowed under his adrenaline. Izuku's pulse thundered in his ears, and reflex took over. He lunged and did the only thing he could do. The only thing that promised at the end of all this, Katsuki would be safe. With his face covered in blood and tears, he aimed for Tomura's heart too.

For a single heartbeat, they were mirrors. Two brothers forged in the same pit of vipers.

Izuku screamed and drove forward.

And then—Tomura shifted. At the very last instant, his blade veered, not for Izuku's heart but for his wrist—a move to disarm, not to kill.

Izuku's eyes widened in shock. He tried to pull back, but the momentum was already spent.

It carried through.

His machete sank into Tomura's chest with a bloody, final sound.

Tomura jerked, a breath escaping from him in a broken choke. They locked eyes, frozen in shock, staring at the irreversible truth of what happened. Suddenly, Tomura's body stuttered, and the next step he took changed the whole mood—and paralyzed Izuku. The world shifted into hues of red as Tomura weakly swayed on his feet, something he's never done.

His brows furrowed. Confusion flashed first in his eyes. Then betrayal. Then finally—hurt.

His gaze dropped slowly, dragging down to the blade buried deep in his chest.

“You—” he rasped. A cough tore through him and spilled crimson across his chin. “You actually…”

Izuku’s eyes flew wide.

Reality struck him, and he let go of the hilt of the blade. He stared at Tomura’s heart, already bleeding through the shirt. One inhale at a time, his breath broke down into sharp, panicked bursts.

“No…” Izuku’s voice cracked apart. “I-I didn’t—”

Dark blood welled fast, spilling down Tomura’s chest. His brother stumbled backwards with one trembling hand clawing helplessly at the hilt and the other reaching for balance that wasn’t there. When he began to fall, Izuku tried to catch him—but his poisoned body betrayed him. His knees finally collapsed.

They collided together, momentum dragging them both down the altar stairs.

The world blurred.

In the fall, the vial slipped from Tomura’s hand. It fell with them, pulled down by the inescapable force of gravity. It arced in the colored light before shattering across the floor at the same time both Izuku and Tomura hit the ground.

The liquid spilled next to them, stretching across the floor.

They laid side by side at the bottom of the altar steps, blood winding together like twin vipers coiling into one. Izuku’s chest heaved in shallow gasps, his trembling body racked with sobs as tears burned down his face.

Beside him, Tomura convulsed. He choked as he spat another mouthful of blood across the floor. The whole time, their eyes remained locked—both wide and stunned.

Izuku shook his head, coughing crimson down his chin. “I…I thought,” he wheezed, face crumbling down. “I thought you were going for the kill.”

For the first time in his life, Tomura laughed. It was sad, and almost human.

“I told you,” he whispered, blood flecking his lips, “I’d never kill you.”

The words crushed Izuku. Tears came heavy and fast, and the weight of what he’d done slammed down until it felt like his heart was the one split open. He sobbed, powerless and unable to move.

Tomura’s gaze softened. In that moment, a complicated warmth flickered in his fading eyes. He lifted a trembling hand, and with the last inch of tenderness he had, he brushed a matted curl behind Izuku’s ear.

Izuku’s chest caved with a sob, tears spilling rampantly. “I’m—I’m sorry, Big Brother.”

Tomura's hand slipped away, thudding limply against the floor. His breath shuddered once, then ebbed out. Steadily, his body slackened and collapsed into stillness. And then his gaze drifted into the unfocused quiet of death.

Izuku screamed soundlessly, throat too raw for anything more. His vision blinked in and out, but through it he saw the faint shimmer of the shattered anti-venom. He craned his neck, feeling as if he was fighting against the weight of the world.

He looked at Katsuki, his Kacchan, still laying unconscious at the top of the altar. Izuku's heart clenched.

He looked towards the spilled antidote and with his arms, he dragged himself forward.

But his body didn't cooperate. Instead, the poison fought him every step of the way. He clawed across the floor, leaving smears of blood in his wake, trying so desperately hard to go to the puddle that was inches away.

However, it was too late. All his energy was spent and his body was gone.

He collapsed with his trembling hand outstretched towards the vial's remains. His eyes found Katsuki's figure through the haze one last time, and tears spilled over his cheeks as his lips parted in a broken cry.

"Kacchan…" Izuku's voice cracked, tears falling with the syllables. "I'm sorry…"

His body gave out and the darkness on the edges of his world seeped in from all sides. He stayed focused on Katsuki, appreciating one last time the view of the man he loved. Then slowly, the shadows finally held his hand and took him along, blackening his vision until there was nothing left but darkness.

Darkness.

Pure, airless darkness swelled all around.

Katsuki drifted in it, weightless, like he was buried alive all over again. The atmosphere was thick and pressed hard against his ribs. In the dream, he couldn't tell if his chest was still rising and falling. There was no ground beneath him and no ceiling above. Only an endless, suffocating black.

And then, through the void, a voice.

It was fragile, but unmistakable.

"Kacchan…"

The word whispered through the shadows. It was thin, but it pulled him. It tugged him along by his heart, urging him to come forward. His pulse thudded and his fingers twitched.

"I'm sorry…"

Izuku.

The name ignited his mind like fire catching tinder. The shadows pressed tighter trying to keep him, but Katsuki struggled against them. His body screamed to stay down, but his need to get back to Izuku burned hotter and hotter until a bright light cracked through the black.

And with a frantic gasp, Katsuki's eyes snapped open.

A splitting, skull-deep pain throbbed in his head, as if a brick had been broken against the back of it. His trembling hand rose, gripping his scalp. And when he pulled it away, it came back full of blood. His vision swam, frantic. His eyes clawed through the haze until the scene around him snapped into focus.

The first thing he saw was blood.

It was all over. It was on him, the windows, the floor and the walls.

And then his eyes landed at the bottom of the altar—and his whole world broke.

"*Izuku*!" Katsuki screamed, voice splintering in two.

Ignoring the skull splitting migraine, he scrambled forward. Every breath he took burned as he dropped to his knees beside Izuku's limp body. Desperately, he checked his pulse. But when he did, his worst nightmare became a reality. Izuku was going cold, and barely breathing.

For one split second, his gaze cut to Tomura beside him. The man's white hair was soaked in scarlet and his own machete jutted from his chest. His face was slack too—and a wave of nausea hit Katsuki so hard he nearly doubled over.

"Izuku," Katsuki cried, as he gathered him in his arms.

His eyes whirled around, searching for the bottle of anti venom, and then his heart sunk all the way to the bottom of his being when he saw it next to them, broken. The vial was shattered completely, and the liquid was all over across the floor.

With one single look, Katsuki gazed at Izuku's lips and knew what to do.

He bent down, cradling Izuku tighter. With no hesitation, he pressed his mouth to the filthy floor, dragging the acrid taste of chemicals, dirt, and glass bits into his mouth. He spat the shards out, then turned back. As gentle as possible, Katsuki cupped Izuku's jaw and pressed their lips together, transferring the anti venom through a kiss.

He pulled back, and his eyes darted all over for signs of life.

Izuku gagged. He choked reflexively and some of it spilled back, dripping down his chin.

A curse slipped between Katsuki's teeth. "C'mon, Izuku. Swallow. Fucking *please*."

But it wasn't working. Why wasn't it fucking working? With only one idea in mind, he clamped a hand around Izuku's throat. He tried to stop his fingers from shaking as he kneaded the muscles. Tears blurred his eyes as he tried his best to coax Izuku's reflexes to work. And then—he felt the swallow catch.

Katsuki's eyes widened.

It was weak, but it was enough.

He dove back down to the puddle of anti-venom, and pulled up as much as he could.

He did this again and again. He painfully repeated the process of kissing life back into the person who had put it back into him. His lips burned with glass cuts—but he pushed forward, begging Izuku to stay with him.

"Please, Izuku. Wake up, damnit."

By the end, Katsuki's tongue burned with the anti venom, but he had picked up every drop he could scavenge. He held Izuku in his arms, trembling and panting fully ragged. He continued to shake him, tears progressively falling as he feared for Izuku's weak pulse.

"My…blazer," a weak rasp whispered, barely audible.

Katsuki's head snapped toward the voice. There, barely clinging to life, was Tomura.

His pale eyes flickered, and blood dripped from the corner of his mouth. Every breath sounded like it was hurting him to take.

"I…I got…a dose…" Tomura gasped, voice thin as paper, trembling with the last of his strength. "When I thought…he was going to…poison himself."

Katsuki's heart skipped.

He sprung for the blazer, fingers fumbling for the inner pocket.

At that same instant, Tomura's head lolled back. His eyes went half-lidded, and the fight inside them unraveled thread by thread. His breathing slowed into fragile, fractured gasps. Then ebbed into silence.

For a moment, the air itself seemed to hold its breath.

It felt unreal that someone who had clawed his way through life from the bottom would succumb to his mortality. But really, Tomura hadn't surrendered to death. No, he'd been thwarted by the one weakness he could never purge from himself.

His gaze drifted to where Izuku lay. And for the first time in years, perhaps the only time in his life, his face softened. No rage. No bitterness. No resentment. His eyes clouded over, fixed on the brother he lost long before this moment.

True serenity passed through him as he took his final breath.

His chest went completely still.

An identical vial slipped into Katsuki's hands, almost too perfectly intact. With shaking fingers, he tore the lid off with his teeth and poured it desperately into Izuku's mouth. He guided the liquid down by massaging Izuku's throat, forcing him to swallow every last drop.

And then—footsteps.

A cluster of people came running towards the front door. Unfamiliar voices echoed beyond, and all of Katsuki's panic shot through the roof.

"Tomura's signal came from in here!" Someone shouted. "Quickly, search the parameter!"

Katsuki rapidly gathered Izuku in his arms and bolted for the hallway. He stumbled as his feet flew, cradling Izuku's head against his chest. Right as the door was slammed open, Katsuki turned and saw the one place he knew no one would look.

He fumbled for the small door under the stairs as the footsteps grew closer.

With a heavy thud, he dropped to his knees. He hurriedly shuffled both him and Izuku inside the small space. They were too big now, and their limbs tangled together in the compact room, but still Katsuki made it work. He rested Izuku's head against the dusty pillow beneath the old posters and closed them in tightly.

He cupped Izuku's head, shielding his face against his chest, and buried his own trembling breaths into Izuku's hair.

Outside, muted gasps of shock cut through the night.

"Oh my god," whispered one voice, dripping with disbelief. "I think he's…dead."

Footsteps echoed, drawing closer, slow and uncertain.

"Search everywhere! They couldn't have gotten far!"

Then, a pause. A groan, faint at first, began to grow.

"Hey…" Another trembling voice whispered. "I feel really sick suddenly…"

Katsuki froze, every nerve screaming. Then came the wrenching sounds. They were horrid, grating, and probably bloody no doubt. Panic erupted in muffled screams and confusion. Directly after came the sick symphony of bodies collapsing one by one. Shoes clattered helplessly against the floor as people tried to scramble but it was useless.

They couldn't outrun poison.

Each groan made Katsuki squeeze Izuku tighter. He buried Izuku's face in the crook of his neck. Outside, the terrible sounds continued on. A horrifying cadence of bodies hitting the ground and cries came as everyone seemed confused by the poison taking them.

And finally, silence.

Katsuki tightened his arms. He shuddered out a terrified breath, and screwed his eyes shut. He tried to wake up. This had to be a dream. It had to be. This was one of his horrible, twisted goddamn nightmares. Because this wasn't how this was supposed to go at all.

Then, a faint cough brushed against his neck.

Katsuki nearly lost his breath. He jerked back in relief and saw Izuku's lashes flutter. The other man's eyes pulled open with agonizing slowness. Quickly, Katsuki's hands flew to his face, cradling the fevered skin. His thumb pressed desperately over Izuku's pulse—only to find it thinning.

He was slipping away.

"Izuku, just hang in there, okay?" Katsuki begged. "Stay with me."

Izuku's lips pulled into a faint, sorrowful curve. He hated that he knew what type of smile that was. It was the kind of smile that already held a goodbye. Izuku was gazing up at him as if it were the last time he'd ever see him—and it destroyed him.

"You found your way back to me," Izuku whispered, voice so thin it nearly disappeared in the dark.

Katsuki's face broke apart. His grip tightened as if he could hold Izuku here by force.

"Of course I did," he whispered. "Again and again, remember?"

"I missed you…so much," Izuku murmured. His eyes blinked slowly and unevenly. "I'm… I'm going to miss you."

"Don't say that, you can't die on me, Izuku," Katsuki rasped, tears streaking down his cheeks. He shook Izuku lightly, desperate to keep him tethered. "C'mon, darling, keep your eyes open. J-Just talk to me. Aizawa will be here soon. I'm sure of it. You just have to hold on a little longer, and we'll get you help, I swear it."

But Izuku's gaze was unfocused, pupils drifting. Fear crept onto his face, as if he could already see the end approaching.

"I…I don't think I'm going to make it, Kacchan." A single tear slipped down Izuku's freckled cheek. "I'm so sorry."

"Don't you fucking say that," Katsuki snapped. His chest heaved, and something inside him fell apart. He realized there was only one thing left to cling to. It was the one thing he'd spent his whole life spitting on, denying, mocking—until this moment. "You're going to make it. Because it's—"

He swallowed hard and let the word burn its way out.

"—It's fate."

Light sparked in Izuku's eyes, surprised. His lips curved into the softest, most fragile smile Katsuki had ever seen. With what little strength he had left, his eyes refocused, he looked up, and he reached out for Katsuki's hand. They gazed at each other, full of love.

"I thought you didn't believe in fate?" Izuku asked.

Katsuki cradled his lover's cheek, thumb brushing away the tears. He smiled back.

"For you, I do."

Izuku's face lit up, and for a moment, it seemed like he was holding on. But then slowly his light faded again. It went out gently, like a vanishing, blinking star in the night sky. His perfect green eyes stared up at Katsuki, scared but tranquil, and then his hand went slack. He lost his grip as his eyes slipped shut.

Katsuki's face crumbled in heartbreak.

"No—no, no, no," he whispered in denial. "Izuku. *Please*—"

Katsuki shook him. He begged Izuku to open his eyes again and to come back. He promised him everything. The sun, the moon, the stars and anything he could think of. But Izuku didn't wake back up. His body remained limp, and his pulse progressively slowed.

He looked at his watch. It was 22:22.

His chest split with a grief so vast it shattered soul.

Behind his eyes, he could see a transparent figure of the boy with pretty green eyes. His friend smiled brightly and sweetly called him 'Kacchan.' One last time, the boy tucked him in and gave him a kiss on the cheek. He looked back once, then exited the nook with a wistful smile.

"Don't go," Katsuki sobbed, cradling Izuku closer. "Please, don't leave me."

Chapter End Notes

:') .... bright side, only up from here? ❤️ Thanks so much for reading!

Chapter 49: Decrescendo

Chapter Summary

Decenscendo (volume) — a decrease in loudness in a piece of music.

Chapter Notes

Hellooo! Welcome back!! I hope you all had a great week. I bring you another chapter that accidentally made me cry :') I hope you enjoy <3 And big thank you again to the LOML, Luna, for being the Beta beast she is!!

Enjoy ❤️

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 49 — Decrescendo

.

.

.

Katsuki sobbed until his throat was stripped bare.

Every part of him throbbed with pain. His arms trembled. His legs shook. Even his lungs were barely cooperating; every breath ground through him like stone against stone. But none of it compared to the harrowing ache in his chest. His heart wasn't breaking anymore—it was caving in, entirely crushed under the thought that Izuku might be gone.

He cried so much his tears soaked Izuku's hair and streaked both their faces. Some irrational, desperate part of him hoped that the sound of his pathetic ass crying might pull Izuku back.

But it didn't.

The love of his life remained motionless in his arms, breathing shallow and unevenly. Each fragile rise of his chest came slower than the last, like a dying ember trying to hold its glow. It was the most devastating sound Katsuki ever heard. Too soft, dwindling, and final. He knew that when it stopped, the silence would destroy him.

He clutched Izuku closer, burying his face against the curve of his neck. His lips brushed against cold skin as he whispered all the apologies his trembling mouth could form. The words tangled together, breaking apart between sobs. Regret poured from him like floodwater.

But no matter how many times he whispered please or come back, Izuku stayed unbearably still.

Then suddenly, a wave of footsteps breached the church. Katsuki froze, every muscle locking with dread. He braced for the sound of guns cocking and more shouting. It was probably the Yakuza again, coming to figure out what happened to their fallen comrades.

But then, through the echoing footsteps, came a voice he knew.

“What the *fuck* happened here—”

Katsuki’s eyes flew open. That was Monoma.

He’d never been more relieved to hear that grating, arrogant voice.

“Over here!” Katsuki shouted, voice frayed. He rose and frantically banged his bloody hand against the small nook door. “We’re over here!” He grappled for the handle, and shoved it open, letting in all the cold air.

The freezing temperature hit him hard, but still he dragged himself out on his knees with Izuku limp in his arms. As he stood, blood clung to him in sticky patches, matting his clothes, his skin, and his hair. It was on Izuku too—too damn much of it—and Katsuki’s stomach turned at the sight.

“*Help*—” he gasped. He tried to shout again, but all that came out was air and panic.

His teammates rushed to him. Through his dizzy haze, Katsuki could make out Aizawa, Monoma, Sero, Shinsou, and Miruko. Their faces dropped in horror when they caught sight of Izuku. Instantly, everyone’s hands began grabbing and steadying him. Several voices overlapped in disarray and alarm.

“Is he breathing?” Shinsou asked, pale.

“We’ve been searching everywhere for you, Bakugou!” Aizawa yelled at him, full of concern. “How the hell did you end up on this side of the city?”

“Are you okay?” Sero asked wearily, looking at the gashes covering his body. “The group chasing us suddenly all passed out without warning—”

Katsuki tried to answer them, but the world tilted. He tipped on his feet, swaying.

Quickly, Monoma made a move to grab Izuku from him. But Katsuki refused. His arms tightened and he shook his head as fresh tears started to come on.

“Izuku needs mamushi anti-venom,” Katsuki’s voice cracked, breaking under the strain of dismay. “Please. We need to hurry.”

Clear confusion filled everyone, but no one asked questions.

“I can get it,” Miruko said confidently. She gave Katsuki a reassuring nod. “We’ll meet you at HQ and I can begin to give him treatment.”

They moved quickly after that. Everyone helped guide them out of the chapel as he stumbled with Izuku in his arms.

As they passed through the front, Katsuki’s gaze caught on Tomura.

There, his pale face peacefully rested. His dead body was laid out among the others collapsed across the chapel floor. Through his shirt, red pooled from his bleeding heart encircling him. His once stark white hair was now deep crimson, saturated in a mix of his and Izuku’s blood. The colorful stained glass window painted his scarred face in shimmering reds, greens, and gold in the moonlight.

And he was utterly still.

A strange, unspeakable feeling inside of Katsuki’s chest twisted. He held Izuku tighter and forced himself to keep walking.

“Grab Tomura’s body,” Katsuki hoarsely whispered to Monoma.

Immediately, his colleague reacted appalled. But with one glimpse at Izuku, he seemed to consider where Katsuki was coming from. Quietly, Monoma grabbed Shinsou and jutted his head towards Tomura’s stiff corpse. The two back walked and lifted the heavy body off the ground.

Outside, the night was unrecognizable. Snow had fallen heavily while they were trapped inside, blanketing the whole world in an eerie silence. In the front of the church, the two waiting cars gleamed under the city lights with their engines rumbling.

The team moved fast, every motion fueled with urgency. Shinsou and Monoma hauled Tomura’s limp body into the trunk while Miruko slammed the lid shut. Denki jumped into the back seat without a word. In the next car, Sero slid into the passenger seat as Katsuki climbed in the back with Izuku cradled securely against his chest.

Aizawa flung himself behind the wheel, and the moment the doors slammed, the engine roared to life and they tore down the street.

“Sorry it took so long to get you,” Aizawa said as he began to drive aggressively. “The streets are absolutely a goddamn mess. Getting to your GPS signal from the original extraction point was a nightmare.”

As the car pulled out into the main street, Katsuki turned to look out the window.

All around them, Tokyo was in chaos under the blood moon. Traffic was grid locked bumper to bumper, and ambulances wailed in every direction. Thick, suffocating crowds pressed onto the sidewalks. Inside them, some people were screaming, and others were wailing. And some were collapsed lifelessly in the snow. The underground crowds had spilled up, and it was sheer mayhem.

Aizawa's weary eyes cut to one group of police officers. They were gathered around, shoving people back as they zipped up three body bags on the sidewalk.

"What the hell happened?" Sero whispered.

Katsuki looked down in his arms. His eyes burned as he stared at Izuku's blood-streaked face.

The only genuine explanation he could give left him somber and bitter.

"…A real tragedy."

☽ ☽ ☽

Traffic getting out of Tokyo was exactly like Aizawa said—a fucking mess.

Every time they cut someone off, they jammed further into the gridlock because in the streets were people shouting and breaking down. News reporters were striving to get into the thick crowd, attempting to figure out what was going on.

Once they cleared the heart of the city, Aizawa drove as if the roads were burning beneath them. He cut corners too tight and clipped curbs without hesitation. Every swerve and jolt was a gamble against time as they perilously raced to reach HQ before Izuku's body surrendered. It was cutting close. He was clinging to a faint thread of life through the anti-venom he received far too late.

When they finally arrived, they barged into The Company's reinforced doors in a rush of urgency.

They all began to run in a full sprint, heading straight towards the medical branch of their HQ. Above them, fluorescent lights streaked overhead and all the walls blurred with the rush of bodies.

In the panic, Aizawa and Miruko shouted at anyone in their way to move. Beside Katsuki, Monoma, Sero and Shinsou ran grim-faced. All of their eyes were locked on Izuku, who's head was bobbing with every jolt, sinking deeper into unconsciousness.

The whole run, Katsuki was profusely sweating and his vision was spotting—but he didn't give a damn.

Because Izuku's lips were officially a petrifying shade of blue.

The second they entered the medical branch of The Company, Miruko hit the ground running.

“Clear the hall!” She yelled. Her voice carried expeditiously as she began sprinting down the white corridors, gathering people to attention with a vial in her hands. “Someone get me a stretcher—*now*! Prep this mamushi anti-venom, IV lines, and monitors—*move*!”

A gurney flew towards them, and dozens of medical workers’ hands began reaching for Izuku’s limp body. Without a word, the medics wrenched Izuku from his arms and placed him on the stretcher. They wheeled him quickly into a private room, already hooking up tubes to his arms.

Katsuki stumbled after them, heart in his throat.

When he got in the room, his eyes watered in fear. Syringes snapped, bags were hung and machines whirred warnings. Miruko’s hands were steady as she administered a generous dose of anti-venom directly into Izuku’s bloodstream through a needle.

“Get some fluids running,” Miruko told someone beside her. “We’re going to need to get him breathing support.”

Katsuki pressed closer, panic digging at his ribs. He looked at Izuku’s chest and noticed it was no longer rising and falling. His eyes widened in horror.

“He stopped breathing,” Katsuki whispered in shock. His eyes grew wider and wider and his inhales pulled sharply. “Why isn’t he breathing?!”

“Bakugou, step back,” a nurse said. “We’re going to need you to back up—”

“I’m not leaving him,” Katsuki hissed. His eyes tethered to the heart monitor, and the jagged line began beeping weaker.

“Crash cart—we need one over here!” Someone shouted.

Katsuki’s knees nearly buckled. His arms curled at his sides, nails digging into his palms as he shook.

Across the large room, the others began getting treated. Sero groaned as a medic cut into his sleeve, Shinsou muttered through clenched teeth, and Monoma winced at a stitch—but Katsuki couldn’t tear his eyes away from Izuku’s unconscious body.

A firm hand tapped his shoulder. He flinched and turned his wide, frantic eyes on Miruko.

“You need treatment too,” she said.

“I—I *can’t*. Not now.” Katsuki’s breath hitched, breaking into a ragged cough.

“You’re bleeding from multiple wounds,” Miruko pushed, gentler now. “If you collapse, who’s going to be there when he wakes up?”

“Don’t make me leave him.” Katsuki’s voice collapsed, choked by heartbreak.

Miruko didn’t argue. She only sighed and nodded to the doctors, who were under her orders.

Two physicians came in then and gently guided him to a hospital bed next to Izuku's. They ordered him around and eventually stripped him of his ruined shirt and pants. Various hands sterilized the deep gashes on his body and wrapped gauze around his limbs.

He winced when Miruko's fingers pressed along his sides.

"You've got multiple displaced ribs," Miruko said, regretful. "Bakugou. If we don't get you into surgery now, one of them is going to pierce a lung."

Katsuki shook his head hard, panic rising in his throat. "No. Not while he's—"

Monoma's voice came then, angry enough to cut through his grief. "If you go down, you won't be able to tell him how sorry you are."

Katsuki stiffened.

He turned to his colleague, who was getting a gunshot wound patched up.

"Isn't that right?" Monoma said with a determined stare. "You haven't told him you're sorry about the deal yet. So you need to go get your sorry ass in surgery. You have to be in good enough shape to grovel when he wakes up."

"Right." Katsuki's jaw clenched, and he nodded. "I…I still have to tell him I'm sorry."

He took a steady inhale and forced himself still as the stretcher came near. He hated the weakness in his body, and the fear of leaving Izuku's side was too much for him to handle. But he didn't fight the hands hauling him toward the doors. Aizawa and Miruko helped him onto the stretcher, and when he settled down, the terror in his gut multiplied.

The stretcher moved, and he craned his neck.

He kept his eyes locked on Izuku until the doors shut.

☽ ☽ ☽

When Katsuki stirred awake from the deep haze of anesthesia, pain greeted him.

He could feel the tug of stitches biting along his skin and the dull weight of steel plates holding his broken bones together. He groaned in the morning light. This much brightness felt wrong somehow.

With a soft groan, he sat up slowly. Immediately, his eyes searched for Izuku.

His tired gaze flicked around and then stopped, finding exactly who he was looking for. There Izuku was, lying in a large hospital bed directly beside him, still unconscious. He was hooked up to a maze of IVs and a ventilator that rose and fell steadily with each artificial breath.

All around them were white walls, different from the ones before. But when he took a second, Katsuki remembered this room. He'd woken here more times than he cared to count

after bungled assignments. It was one of the private infirmary suites on the highest floor of their HQ. This section held agents whose wounds were too severe to ignore but too dangerous to explain in a public hospital.

His vision focused, and across the way he saw a cluster of figures. Each one sat rigid, staring intently at a TV mounted on the wall.

Aizawa was in a plastic chair and next to him was the whole M-Unit. Monoma was perched on the edge of the room's couch. Beside him Shinsou slouched slightly but his eyes were alert. Even Denki was there, leaning forward while Sero held a scowl fixed on the screen.

Their focus drew Katsuki's gaze.

"What…?" He rasped.

On the TV, a reporter stood. She was in a coat, standing before a tumultuous scene of blinking red and blue lights. Behind her, police tape flapped in the wind, and hundreds of body bags were being lined up for identification.

"A shocking, disturbing night has fallen upon Tokyo," she said grimly. "Bizarre rumors are circulating about what occurred, but details remain unclear. What is confirmed is horrifying: a mass murder. Authorities confirmed that over five hundred people died, including the Governor of Tokyo and his wife."

Katsuki's spine straightened. He leaned forward, bewildered by the number.

Five *hundred*?

"Deceased individuals were found scattered throughout the area and confirmed to be poisoned," she continued. "Some bodies have been discovered in a previously unknown underground city, which was hidden beneath Tokyo. A place called 'Hadeus' that our public officials didn't know existed until now. It seems to be a free for all for crime, mobsters, and highly illegal activity. A giant crack down unlike ever before has begun."

The reporter paused and glanced behind her with a glum expression.

"Authorities are investigating the incident, which appears to be linked to organized crime. Some witnesses, though reluctant, report that the attack took place during a wedding tied to the notorious and elusive Chisaki family. Many people, however, are refusing to speak to the police."

Katsuki's chest tightened further as he looked at everyone's serious expressions.

"Because of the attire many victims wore, black, gold, or dark green, media outlets have begun referring to this incident as The Venomous, Viridian Wedding," she finished, low and serious. "We'll provide more updates during tonight's evening news."

Denki let out a low whistle. "Five hundred people poisoned…that's…insane."

“Maybe it was an inside job,” Shinsou muttered, full of unease. “The Chisakis probably have more enemies than we realize.”

Aizawa’s gaze turned, stopping on Katsuki.

“Bakugou,” he said slowly, “do you have any idea how five hundred people got poisoned, including Izuku?”

Katsuki swallowed thickly, hung his head, and let his gaze fall to the side.

“Izuku did it,” he whispered. His hands crushed the thin hospital blanket in his grip. “He…he told me he put an altered mamushi venom mixture in the wedding cake.”

Silence.

“That can’t be right?” Sero said, confusion showing in his face. “We saw him eat…”

His words died off. For a horrible moment, the room went dead quiet. Katsuki watched as one by one, everyone turned to look at Izuku’s sleeping form. The truth sunk in and it wrapped the whole room in disbelief.

Denki’s eyes shimmered with tears and he covered his mouth. “Oh…oh no.”

Katsuki’s fingers tightened further around the blanket as a combination of guilt and sorrow crashed over him.

“It’s a good thing we got there when we did then,” Aizawa muttered.

His gaze flipped between Katsuki and Izuku, measuring the fragile line between them where everything was balanced. Katsuki didn’t reply. Honestly, he couldn’t even if he wanted to. His mind was racing with too many damn thoughts to grab hold of a single one.

Aizawa stood and crossed the room, keeping his footsteps quiet.

He came to Katsuki’s bedside, and together they stared down at Izuku’s still form.

“He’s stable,” Aizawa informed him gently. “The doctors were able to pull him back from the brink. The only thing, his breathing’s weak. But otherwise he’s holding on.”

Katsuki nodded, pleased to know.

“So he’s just sleeping?” He asked. “He’ll wake up a little later or something?”

Aizawa pressed his lips into a thin line. He glanced around the room, and suddenly everyone else’s eyes skirted off to the side or looked down to the ground. Katsuki frowned when Shinsou exhaled a heavy sigh and turned toward the window. Then suddenly Monoma’s head dropped, and shame clouded Sero’s face. Even Denki’s gaze faltered, and he couldn’t lift his eyes to meet Katsuki’s.

A sinking sensation in his gut began to grow.

“What?” Katsuki pressed. “What’s wrong? Why are you all looking like that?”

“Well.” Aizawa hesitantly put his hand on Katsuki’s shoulder, as if to brace him. “We’re unsure.”

Katsuki whipped this head up. “*Hah*? What the hell do you mean you’re unsure?”

“While you were in surgery,” Aizawa explained delicately, “it was determined that he’s… fallen into a coma.”

Katsuki stared, not blinking. “A coma? Izuku’s in a coma?”

“Yes.” Aizawa gave the faintest nod. He glanced at Monoma, who still wouldn’t raise his eyes. “He was extremely close to passing away when we arrived. The doctors did everything they could, but the venom was already too far along. His body’s in shock, and the lack of oxygen forced him into shutdown. We can’t predict when or if he’ll wake up.”

Katsuki’s jaw worked as he tried to hold it together, but the pain still bled through in the glassiness in his eyes.

“The only thing we can do is wait,” Aizawa finished in a whisper.

All around the room, silence stretched on.

Monoma’s brow furrowed tight, Sero’s head hung low, and Denki and Shinsou traded guilt-ridden glances.

No one could speak.

In the background, the television still played. The news unraveled the endless string of events that plunged Tokyo into pandemonium. On top of that sound, Katsuki’s own thoughts buzzed loudly.

If only they’d gotten there sooner.

If only he’d been faster. Smarter. Stronger.

If only.

“You did well,” Aizawa reassured. He turned around and looked at each of them with pride. “You all did. I want to be very clear—this was not a failed assignment. I know you’re all feeling like it was because of Izuku’s state, but we got him out. It’s okay. He’ll wake up, I’m sure of it.”

When the silence continued, Aizawa sighed.

He walked to a small duffel bag and pulled out a clean set of clothes for Katsuki. Without a word, he tossed them across the room. Katsuki caught them easily, the fabric soft and heavy in his hands. When he glanced down, he saw that every piece was black.

“Let’s get you all some food,” Aizawa suggested to the room. “We need to debrief about the assignment.”

They all nodded. Everyone began walking to the door, and Katsuki breathed tiredly.

Left alone to change, Katsuki drifted toward Izuku’s bedside. He stood there for a sobering moment, studying the other man. Izuku’s eyes were shut, and his long lashes brushed against his freckled cheeks. He looked peaceful as he took limited, fragile breaths. Katsuki noted someone tried to clean the blood off him, but there was still a trace of stubborn rust color along his chin.

With the utmost care, Katsuki brushed Izuku’s bangs aside.

Then, right when he was about to leave, he caught sight of something shiny on Izuku’s left hand. He frowned and cocked his head. His curiosity pulled at him. But when he lifted Izuku’s hand up—his blood boiled. Searing rage burned straight through him, and darkness eclipsed his eyes.

Sitting on Izuku’s ring finger was an obscene single-rock diamond ring. It was gaudy, caked in crimson, and screamed the disgusting wealth of the Chisakis.

Without a moment’s hesitation, he snatched it off. His chest heaved, and his nostrils flared violently. He tried to contain himself. But all he could feel was infinite failure.

Failure. Failure. Failure.

Fucking *failure*.

With an excruciating yell, he hurled the ring across the room. The sound of it striking the wall rang like a gunshot. It pathetically clattered to the floor, mocking him as it reflected back the morning light. As it sparkled, his pain tripled. It folded on itself, and took him with it. Katsuki’s eyes welled up and he frustratingly wiped the tears away.

He gripped Izuku’s left hand.

“I’m so sorry,” Katsuki hissed. “I should’ve gotten there sooner.”

☽ ☽ ☽

When the day wound down, everyone became quiet. Their unit drifted in silence with that awkward, tired shuffle people made after something terrible concluded. With the debrief done, the assignment was officially complete. And aside from him, the others only suffered minor injuries, so there wasn’t much else to be done.

During their meeting, Aizawa learned the extent of what took place. He seemed marginally mortified when they described the various Vipers and Yakuza dropping like flies. But he was happy to know One, or whatever the hell his name was, was officially dead.

Aizawa signed off on the last bit of Izuku’s green folder and sealed it shut.

“Well,” Miruko sighed. She leaned back in the chair and grimaced. “I guess there’s just the matter of that dead guy in my trunk. What should we do with him?”

All eyes swung to Katsuki.

He frowned intensely. In the crease between his eyes, he could feel a new wrinkle form from how displeased he was.

Bitterly, Katsuki mumbled under his breath, “For now, let’s put him in the deep freezer in the basement. That’ll stop him from…decaying.” He inhaled. “If it takes Izuku too long to wake up, then…then I guess we’ll have to dispose of him ourselves.”

Sero gave him a cautious glance. “No offense, but I think that guy is better off rotting away, Bakugou.”

“I *fully* agree,” Katsuki spat.

Anger flared inside him like a live flame. It was hot, immediate, and truly damn endless. He despised Tomura with every fiber he was made of, and his hatred hadn’t vanished just because the man was dead. If anything, it multiplied. Because now, Izuku was lying in a coma because he thought the only way out of his brother’s abuse was to take his own life.

Honestly, Katsuki didn’t give a damn that Tomura spent his final breath saving Izuku’s life. After everything, it was the bare fucking minimum. But Katsuki’s fury shifted into exhaustion the longer he dwelled on the bastard’s last moments.

His shoulders sagged as he sighed.

“…But I know Izuku,” Katsuki continued with distant eyes. “After what happened, Izuku is going to wake up and be worried about what happened to his brother’s body. So. For Izuku’s sake, I think he should have closure, however it looks for him. Tomura was his brother, despite everything.”

Everyone at the table became silent, but no one disagreed.

Eventually, they made their way out to the van parked in the back lot. They opened up the trunk and all of them stared down at the dead body. As they stood there, there was a strange serenity to the corpse that made Katsuki’s resentment burn hotter. The usual terror that carved people’s faces when they died wasn’t there. Instead, Tomura was serene.

It was as if his last moments were in peace and not in pain.

☽ ☽ ☽

The freezer room was covered in frost. Every exhale Katsuki took came out in a puff of white, vanishing into the bright, silver room. With a grunt, Katsuki and Monoma hauled Tomura’s weight onto a steel tray. His hefty corpse landed with a loud thud, reminding Katsuki just how much of a force of nature the bastard had been while alive.

Quietly, Katsuki stood over the body for a moment. Tomura's skin was now faded to the color of salt, with dark veins weaving beneath the surface like they'd been painted on.

Monoma wrapped his arms around himself, breath trembling as he stared down too.

"Even in death, he looks intimidating," Monoma groaned.

Katsuki scowled when he thought of Izuku's frail state.

"Let's hurry and seal him in," he muttered.

Together, Katsuki and Monoma opened one of the many containers meant for bodies. The room was lined with them. They looked like giant silver drawers and were marked with plaques carrying information about who was inside. The Company only kept this storage room for freezing dead bodies, typically for Sero and other stagers for whatever needs they had.

Katsuki picked the farthest drawer, half-hidden behind others, slightly out of spite. He gripped the steel handle and pulled it open. They slid the corpse in together and Tomura's inked body gleamed faintly under the fluorescent light. The vipers etched across his neck still looked alive, slithering even now as their black horns twisted with the angle of the light.

When Tomura's feet thudded against the back, Katsuki slammed the door shut harder than he needed to.

Monoma held up a blank tag. "What should we write? El Diablo?"

Katsuki snatched it from him. "No."

He gripped the pen tightly as he scrawled a name in sharp, deliberate strokes. He clipped it to the drawer, and took a large step back. Staring at them was the simple name, 'Mamushi Tomura'.

For a long time, Katsuki just stood there, breathing hard in the frozen air. Then, finally, he turned away and Monoma followed him.

"Rest well, bastard," he muttered.

He flicked off the lights.

☽ ☽ ☽

As nightfall officially came, everyone said goodbye. All his colleagues gave him mixed looks of pity and apology. They all promised they'd come back tomorrow, and solemnly Katsuki nodded along.

Because what else could he really say?

It felt odd. It was like he was stuck in limbo for real this time, tethered to waiting for Izuku to wake up.

He trekked back to the room Izuku slept in, accompanied by Aizawa. When Katsuki gazed around, he finally took in the full look of the hospital suite. It was quaint. White walls with a single blue horizontal stripe, and a generic blue flower painting above the two comfortable twin-sized beds.

“I left you some clothes for the week,” Aizawa said. “I figured you’d want to sleep here until he wakes up.”

“Thanks,” Katsuki whispered quietly.

“I’ll be back in the morning, kid,” Aizawa murmured. “Get a good night’s rest.”

Katsuki waved goodbye and Aizawa did as well. Behind him, the door shut, locking him in alone with Izuku.

Quietly, he went through the motions. He brushed his teeth. He showered. He washed his face and rid himself of all the dried, flaky blood. Every step was a struggle, and his body was still fully screaming out. When he changed into the loose black pajamas and entered back into the room, he stared at the small sliver between the two beds.

Without a word, Katsuki pushed his bed towards Izuku’s, and pressed them flush together.

He climbed onto his side and scooted his pillow as close as possible towards the love of his life. As he hovered over the other man, something metallic around Izuku’s neck caught in the moonlight. Katsuki reached for it, and when he tugged it free, his heart wrenched.

It was the eternity ring, on a golden necklace.

Katsuki lay down beside him, and his hand found Izuku’s. His thumb traced slow circles over the soft skin, memorizing its warmth as if he could anchor Izuku to it. In the quiet, he replayed every moment that led them here. Every mistake. Every desperate choice. Every miscalculated alignment.

He tried with all the strength left in him to will Izuku to wake back up.

“Come back, Izuku,” he whispered. “Please…come back.”

☽ ☽ ☾ ☾

Izuku held hands with the shadows. He couldn’t see anything, but he could feel the warmth of something guiding him through the blackness, laced with his fingers. Something warm stroked gently across the back of his hand. The touch was so achingly familiar that, even through the haze, he knew it meant safety.

So he followed it, step after step, into the endless dark.

As he wandered, a sound reached him. It was soft at first, then it became clearer the closer he came.

It was a woman crying in a heartbreaking way.

He froze, uncertain. But the shadow holding him urged him forward, pulling him towards the sound.

The blackness thinned, splitting open like fog clearing to reveal a scene beyond. Through the jagged gap, he saw Inko. She was crumpled on a small kitchen floor with her face buried in her hands as her shoulders shook. Beside her sat a small boy. It was him, no more than two years old. The child version of himself was crying too. His smaller self leaned towards her, confused, reaching out.

But when his tiny hand touched her shoulder, she flinched as though the contact hurt.

Before he could step closer, the darkness surged back in. It spilled over the image, swallowing it whole.

Izuku stood there, staring into the empty black where the image had been. His chest clamped tight as though a fist closed hard around his heart.

Then, it sparked again. The fog opened up, and suddenly the scene began moving away from him. He tried to keep up with it, chasing the fading scene until another image tore through the darkness. This time, Inko stood in a dark alley with a hood pulled low over her head. Her eyes were bloodshot, and her face was worn and broken. In her trembling arms was him, red-faced and wailing loudly.

“And you’re positive he’ll go to a good family?” she whispered, voice shaking uncontrollably. “I—I can’t…I can’t take care of him the way I thought I could.”

Izuku turned, searching for the person she spoke to, and found it was Koizumi. He was younger, though still almost the same. He possessed a polite posture and a professional smile that didn’t reach his eyes.

“Yes,” Koizumi lied smoothly. “I promise he’ll go to a family that will appreciate him very much.”

Inko nodded hesitantly.

Her hands tightened around her son before she finally let go. She passed the toddler into Koizumi’s waiting arms, and in return he pressed a small bag of cash into her hands. Izuku’s younger self screamed louder, confused. He began flailing while Inko dipped her head and screwed her eyes shut. She counted the bills through her teary vision.

“Ah, he’s a crier,” Koizumi muttered, bouncing the toddler in an awkward attempt to soothe him. “Hey now. It’ll be okay, little guy.”

Inko gave one last, lingering glance at her son. Her lips trembled before she turned and slipped away into the darkness, swallowed whole.

Izuku watched, and his heart broke. His younger self reached out desperately for his mother as Koizumi began walking. His tiny fists clenched, and his sobs began rising louder and

louder as he was pulled away into the abyss.

Izuku saw his mother go, disappearing into the shadows. Inko blurred out of sight, and so he began following behind Koizumi. He walked for what felt like forever, trailing the man further and further into the void.

When Koizumi finally stopped, he stood before Peter Moore. Moore grinned greedily, took the crying toddler, and immediately passed him off again—this time to Ms. Nagant. She frowned and held the toddler at arm's length as though he were something disgusting she didn't quite know what to do with. She then turned and walked on.

Izuku followed her through the darkness too until she stopped. Without a word, she set the toddler down and left him there alone, crying, trembling, and lost.

"Mommy?" his young self whimpered, voice cracking through the black.

Izuku's gaze dropped. Even from here, he could make out the faintest splash of freckles across his nose.

Then suddenly, another figure stepped out of the void. It was Tomura, no older than seven. His hair was still black, and one of his eyes was bruised purple from a fist. He was wearing a frustrated frown and his quivering lip was split and swollen. A deep, crazed anger twisted his young face, yet he approached young Izuku quietly.

Izuku's younger self looked up at Tomura. Tears streaked his cheeks and fear was in his eyes.

"Wh-Who are you?" he whispered.

Young Tomura crouched down apprehensively. He studied Izuku for a moment and slowly his angry expression melted away. Now, young Tomura only looked sad. He reached out and pushed back Izuku's messy hair with surprising gentleness.

"I'm your new big brother," he said.

Izuku stood frozen, watching as his younger self's sobs gradually subsided. The child lifted his arms, and Tomura gathered him close. His brother cradled his head with a strange, protective care. Warmth spread through Izuku's chest as he watched his younger self finally stop crying for the first time.

Then young Tomura turned. His gaze cut past the illusion and locked directly onto Izuku.

Izuku froze.

In those eyes, Izuku saw a vulnerable loneliness. But he also saw endless rage.

Without a word, young Tomura began walking into the blackness. Izuku followed, and as he did, the darkness shifted. It dissolved slowly into their old dorm room. In a strange, nostalgic blur, he watched time fold in on itself and witnessed them grow up together firsthand.

Suddenly, footsteps he could never forget echoed behind him.

Izuku turned, and there adult Tomura was. His brother was exactly as Izuku last saw him. Older, hardened, and the weight of the world carved into his face. His long white hair was flowing down, gracefully pouring over his shoulders. Izuku's whole body tightened as Tomura came to stand silently beside him.

Together, they gazed on at their younger selves growing up side by side.

"It all went by so quickly," Tomura muttered. "Didn't it?"

Izuku blinked back tears, staring at the life before them. "Yeah. It did."

Moments surfaced that he hadn't remembered until now. Tomura letting him curl up in his bed. Tomura hiding him in the closet so no one would hear him cry. Tomura returning from training every night with fresh scars and bruises.

Then came the slow, inevitable shift.

The bitterness in Tomura's eyes transformed into ruthless survival and then into something darker than anger. Izuku observed as the warmth steadily faded from Tomura along with his black hair color. His brother stopped letting him into his bed when Izuku was six and after that, the distance between them widened with each passing year.

By the time Izuku turned seven, it was undeniable. Tomura had grown colder and more calculating. He became a creature of survival alone, and the vow to be the top predator was etched deep in his resolve. Izuku in turn, despite everything, kept growing softer. He secretly curled up with his banned book, and steadily grew warmer and warmer.

Their paths diverged like two lines drawn in opposite directions. And no matter how close they remained in space, Izuku understood that they never truly ever crossed again.

The room shifted, stretching from the cramped dorm into the wide-open expanse of their shared suite. In its walls flickered the flashes of their young adult lives.

They saw it all play out before them: the good, the brutal, and the quiet in-betweens.

Many nights were spent together binging an entire TV show on the couch. Other nights were Tomura hosting the family dinners. Then some days showed them happily getting ice cream as they talked about mundane things.

Then came the brutal bits: Tomura's voice raised in anger and his fist striking Izuku to the ground. The belt beatings. Over and over. The void showed them fighting and breaking expensive items in their storm. Then silence. The darkness replayed the long stretch of days they would spend ignoring each other until one of them caved.

A quiet, bitterness passed between them as one particular memory played before their eyes.

They both watched Tomura quietly cut fruit, place it on a plate, and leave it in front of Izuku's door after he purposefully broke Izuku's nose during a disagreement.

"I…only wanted to make sure we survived," Tomura whispered beside him.

Izuku's eyes stung. His voice wobbled as he answered, "You did."

The scenes slowed, bleeding into stillness. Before them, the suite shifted into the glorious penthouse. Their adult selves played out there too, living through life after Tomura took over Nine's position.

Together, they watched Tomura help him with his skin, and began dressing him better. Izuku went along with it, happily caring for Katsuma in the meantime. Then there was a memory of Izuku playing the violin while Tomura filled out some paperwork. Beside them, Katsuma sat at the kitchen table coloring with crayons.

From this angle, Izuku saw something he hadn't remembered before. While he was playing, his brother glanced over at them and smiled.

Then it all stopped.

Their past selves checked their watches, and began getting ready to leave at the same time. They put on their coats and turned towards the door to go. Slowly, the door opened, and out poured a flood of light.

The illusion of the penthouse burned away until only the door remained, suspended in the void.

Izuku looked around, and now there was nothing but him and his brother.

No memories. No penthouse. No Katsuma.

Only them.

Tomura stepped towards the door, and Izuku followed. Every step was heavy with the weight of everything that transpired between them. Along the way, Tomura glanced back. His face was unreadable in the ethereal glow.

"Looks like it'll always be just you and me, huh?" He said thoughtfully.

Izuku's lips formed a sorrowful smile. "I guess so."

The moment they reached the door, the blinding warmth rolled over them.

It spilled across Izuku's skin like fire and water fusing together. In the light, every ache, every scar, and every fragment of sorrow inside of Izuku melted. For a lovely moment, his body felt weightless, as if he was floating in the comforting promise of eternal peace. He closed his eyes and let the feeling of letting go wash over him.

He breathed it in, trembling with relief and grief all at once.

When he opened his eyes, tears were streaming freely down his cheeks. Tomura already crossed into the light, cloaked entirely in its brilliance. His brother gave him a rare smile and extended a hand, inviting him to join.

Izuku reached toward him—

And then suddenly, something violently yanked him backwards. The shadows gripped his hand, dragging him away from the brilliance.

He blinked, startled.

And then, softly, a familiar voice echoed through the dark. It was Katsuki's. It was high, boyish and calling for him. Izuku turned around, surprised, and the tugging grew stronger.

Out of the shadows came a tiny figure. Katsuki, seven years old, searching desperately.

"Izuku?" Young Katsuki's voice cracked with panic. "Izuku! Where'd you go?"

From behind him, another child's laughter bubbled up. A smaller Izuku darted from the darkness and leapt onto Katsuki with a grin. Katsuki startled, then broke into giggles as their voices tangled together in an innocent melody.

"I'm right here, Kacchan!" Young Izuku laughed. He pressed a quick kiss against Katsuki's cheek. "Now you're it!"

Izuku watched them tumble through the dark, chasing one another in a game of tag. Their laughter echoed faintly, and on their small fingers were the makeshift rings twisted from bits of string. Then, without warning, the shadow holding his hand grew warmer. And somewhere deep in the quiet, he heard the steady thrum of a heartbeat pulsing.

Before him, the other side of his life unfolded: he and Katsuki growing up side by side.

The years played out like a delicate, intricate song: the highs, the lows, the steady climbs, and the sudden pitfalls. He saw them dancing with the violinist, then meeting in Vienna and clashing head-on during assignments.

He witnessed their lives tangle together progressively, year by year, until love bloomed between them. All the years culminated in a stolen kiss under the Okinawa moon with Katsuki holding him like he was the most precious thing in the world.

He watched them sneak away together to Biei and share gentle memories. One showed him and Katsuki laying in a field of flowers, peacefully watching the clouds. Then another showed them laughing unabashed together in the kitchen over a cup of tea.

It showed it all. The soft touches. The quiet kisses. And the gentle caresses. It showed them escaping together to the mountains hand in hand, and then finally the proposal at the orchestra.

Izuku's expression softened, and his chest filled with longing.

"Or I suppose, you were never really alone. Were you?" Tomura murmured from the other side, voice tinged with sadness. "You had someone else this whole time."

Izuku turned, and through the doorway he could see Tomura standing there. Behind him, a faint glow revealed all his siblings. Ibara and Aoyama smiled at him wistfully. Jin and Himiko stared at him, their eyes judgmental yet patient.

Izuku's chest collapsed as he took in the faces of his siblings.

"I didn't want to kill you," Izuku whispered regretfully. He gazed at the others, pain heavy in every word. "I didn't want to kill *any* of you."

"I know," Tomura replied softly.

From behind, a hand gently rested on Izuku's shoulder. He turned to see Hiryu smiling at him before glancing at Tomura.

"I don't think it's quite his time," Hiryu said with a soft laugh. "Maybe a full family reunion will happen in a couple decades, but not today."

Tomura pressed his lips into a thin line.

Hiryu stepped past, offering one last kind smile before joining the others. For a heartbeat, Izuku feared the worst as Tomura and Hiryu's eyes met—but in the light, the tension between them vanished. Hiryu gave Tomura's shoulder a light, brotherly fist bump as he passed, a subtle gesture of reconciliation. He walked on and joined the rest behind him.

Himiko let out a quiet, bittersweet huff. "I guess we'll see you when we see you, runt."

Izuku's chest hurt, but he managed a smile toward her, nodding faintly.

With a small inhale, Tomura crossed back over briefly. He stopped before Izuku, his unreadable expression finally cracked under the weight of what he felt but couldn't say. His eyes searched Izuku's face, lingering, trying to hold on to him and measure the impossibility of what the life between them had been.

Hesitantly, he lifted a hand. His fingers brushed Izuku's stubborn curl behind his ear in a gentle, almost desperate gesture.

"I suppose," Tomura murmured, voice rough with unshed emotion. "If I had to guess what love is…then yes. I loved you in the only way I knew how."

The words washed over Izuku, unspooling the pain he'd carried for so long. His tears fell freely, blurring his vision as he stood frozen, silently letting them fall. Tomura didn't move closer. He only lingered for a moment longer with the faintest shadow of a smile on his lips. He then slowly stepped back towards the bright doorway.

"I'll miss you," Tomura confessed.

Izuku's heart clenched, each beat reminding him that this was final. Truly final.

"I'll miss you too," Izuku cried.

One by one, his siblings faded into the light, faces all heavy with a mix of pride and sorrow. Ibara and Aoyama offered quiet waves. Jin and Himiko nodded at him, carrying the weight of shared history. Hiryu smiled proudly and Tomura stared dolefully.

The door between them creaked shut with agonizing slowness and the whole time Tomura held his gaze.

When the portal finally closed shut, The Viper Seven he knew all faded into the brightness, leaving Izuku in the dark.

The shadows clung to him still. They were heavy and encompassing, but now they felt different. There was warmth there. A small pulse beneath the void. Confused, Izuku focused and then he realized: it wasn't shadows at all holding on to him. It was a hand.

Katsuki's hand.

"Come back, Izuku," Katsuki's voice echoed from the darkness. "Please…come back."

Izuku's chest heaved as he desperately grasped the hand back. Warm was his first thought. His next thought was that he wasn't done, and that there was someone waiting for him. Someone who he didn't want to leave and promised Mitsuki he'd take care of.

Gradually, the weight in his chest began to ease. It transformed as if he shed the last layer of his snake skin. It hurt to let go, but he stepped into the new version of himself through real, agonizing transformation. The searing ache of grief inside of him slowly grew into relief as he found peace in knowing Tomura's endless struggle was over.

The pain of letting go transformed into the beautiful but heavy feeling of solace.

He squeezed Katsuki's hand back.

"Kacchan," he whispered. "I'm coming."

ɯɯɯ

Izuku's eyes fluttered open; the world around him appeared fuzzy and surreal.

For a brief, disorienting moment, he thought he was still in limbo, trapped in a blinding expanse of white. Then, through the blur, he registered the faint outline of a figure. Gradually, the edges sharpened, and he realized it was Miruko. She was wearing a white coat, and her movements were precise and methodical as she withdrew a needle from his vein.

Izuku groaned, and rolled his head away from the ceiling light.

Miruko's eyes snapped to him, wide in shock. "Oh my god—Izuku? Are you awake?"

He tried to speak, but the memories from the church slammed into him with merciless speed.

Flashes assaulted his mind: the stained glass, the vial, and the blood. Katsuki's skull smashing against the wall. The machete piercing Tomura's chest. Each image punched him,

leaving his mind reeling, and a migraine split through his skull.

Then the final memory came like a blow to his gut. The last he saw Katsuki he was battered, unconscious, and drenched in blood.

With a strangled gasp, Izuku bolted upright, eyes wide with panic.

“Katsuki,” he whispered, breathless.

His gaze swept the room frantically, but Katsuki was nowhere to be seen.

Miruko put a hand on his chest, calm but firm. “Izuku, slow down. He’s okay—”

“—I-I’m sorry,” Izuku apologized, pushing aside the gentle caution entirely.

He looked down and noticed he was free of needles and draped in a hospital gown. Ignoring Miruko’s calls, he swung his legs over the edge of the unfamiliar bed. His knees wobbled dangerously and nearly gave way, but he gripped the small table beside him for support.

Slowly and shakily, he pushed forward. His legs carried him with a will of their own as he limped towards the door.

“Katsuki?” he called, voice hoarse. “Katsuki!”

He stumbled into the hallway, every step echoing against the white tiles. His chest heaved as he wheezed for air. But another desperate bellow tore from his throat again, bouncing down the corridor.

“*Kacchan*!”

Then he heard it. The familiar, heavy, fast-footed steps answering the frantic rhythm of his own heart. He whipped around, chest hammering, and there he was. Katsuki bursted from a room at the far end of the hall.

His eyes were wild as he searched around and when he turned towards Izuku, time seemed to stop.

They both ran, closing the space between them with desperate speed.

Every step was charged with relief and longing. Izuku outstretched his arms, and Katsuki did the same. And when they finally collided, it was as if the world itself twisted around them in a halo of warmth.

The force of their collision spun them in a dizzying whirl. Izuku was lifted clean off the ground, and he buried his face in the crook of Katsuki’s neck, inhaling the reality of him being alive.

Katsuki pressed his face hard against Izuku’s shoulder, his grip trembling violently as though he feared letting go would tear Izuku away again. His breath came in ragged gasps against Izuku’s skin, breaking with sobs he could no longer contain. Their tears mingled in the space

between them, fully unrestrained. Every shudder and cry spilled the agony of separation and the fragile relief of being whole again.

Together, they landed gently against the wall with Katsuki's arms tightening around Izuku. In that instant, they were home. Nothing else existed but the two of them, breaking down together, finally reunited.

"You came back," Katsuki whispered into his cheek. He shakily exhaled full of relief. "You actually came back."

Izuku smiled through his sobbing. "Again and again, right?"

"Right." Katsuki grinned and held him tighter. "Again and again."

ᔓᔓᔓ

The room was full, alive with voices, shuffling feet, and the faint sound of the IV drip as clear liquid fed into Izuku's bloodstream.

All around were the people he thought were marked for death, and it felt strange to see them all basking in morning light. Aizawa was leaning on the couch with a newspaper in his hands. Monoma and Shinsou were casually discussing something while Sero and Denki were laughing loudly at a video on Sero's phone.

Peacefully, Izuku leaned back against the pillows with a tiny smile. His hand rested securely in Katsuki's, their fingers were intertwined as they softly gazed at each other. Judging by the new frown lines, Izuku could tell Katsuki probably wore nothing but scowls for however long he'd been out.

On the other side of him, Miruko secured another dressing across his gunshot wound.

"Ah, thank you," Izuku murmured. He turned to her with a hint of embarrassment. "Sorry for the freak out earlier."

"Oh, don't worry." Miruko's laugh was light as she peeled off her gloves. "I'm very used to the dramatics around here."

Katsuki snorted under his breath. "She means Denki."

"Obviously," Miruko agreed, and the room chuckled.

Izuku gave a soft laugh too, careful not to strain his sore stomach. His gaze lowered, settling on the white coat draped over Miruko's frame.

"I didn't know you had a medical background," he said, voice still hoarse.

"There's a lot about me you don't know," Miruko teased, flashing him a wink. She began mixing some medicine for him and leaned back with an affable grin. "But yeah, I actually

started here because Aizawa needed someone with medical knowledge on hand. I've got a medical degree technically."

Izuku's eyes sparked. "Really?"

"Yeah." She smiled softer this time, her usual brashness mellowed in the moment. "I only stuck around because Aizawa and I go way back, and I got curious what his elusive 'cleaning' business was. Now I mostly handle patch jobs for idiots who don't know when to quit—your favorite knucklehead included."

Katsuki rolled his eyes. "Tch. I'm not in surgery that much."

"You literally are my most frequent patient," she said flatly.

"I am not—"

"You are," Aizawa chimed from the other side of the room, expression unimpressed. "I have you under an entirely different insurance because of it."

The laughter spread, filling the space with a warmth Izuku thought was lost forever. The pain in his chest loosened as he looked around. Denki slouched in a chair. Monoma leaned stiffly against the wall with his arms crossed but his eyes soft. Sero grinned happily, and Shinsou was in the corner with his usual quiet watchfulness.

And Katsuki, always Katsuki, his hand wrapped lovingly around Izuku's like he would never let go again.

"I…" Izuku swallowed. He blinked fast before his weak voice could betray the cracks in it. "I missed all of you. Thank you so much. You all put yourselves in danger for me, and I don't know how I can repay you."

Silence fell for a beat, heavy but not uncomfortable. Then Denki huffed out a laugh, a little shaky.

"Man, don't go saying stuff like that," he said through glassy eyes. "You're gonna make us cry."

"You're already crying," Sero pointed out and tossed him a tissue.

Denki caught it and immediately began blowing his nose. "Shut up!"

Izuku laughed again, the gesture hurt but he loved it. He nearly forgot what it was like to feel pure, unweighted joy. As the room broke in light banter, Miruko handed Izuku medicine for the hole in his stomach. He drank it down, and Katsuki's thumb brushed over his knuckles, keeping him steady.

The voices in the room blended into a low, comforting hum around him.

As the others talked Izuku's mind began to wander. His gaze flickered, first to Katsuki's hand around his, then to the steady drip of the IV, then finally across the room to the small

television mounted high in the corner.

It was background noise until it wasn't. The crawl of headlines at the bottom of the screen snagged his attention. Then he saw the passing images of flashing sirens and crime tape across the TV. He tuned everyone out as he watched the news anchors speak with practiced solemnity about hundreds of bodies unearthed from something they were calling The Venomous, Viridian Wedding.

Izuku's brow furrowed.

Then his eyes caught on six numbers far simpler, yet far more devastating.

He stared. Blinked. Stared again.

"I–Is that date right?" Izuku whispered, unsure.

Suddenly, the room quieted. His wide, bewildered eyes stayed glued to the screen.

Katsuki stiffened and sat up straighter. He followed Izuku's gaze, turning just enough to glance over his shoulder. His mouth pressed into a thin, reluctant line.

"Yeah," Katsuki replied at last. "You've…uh, you've been out for two weeks."

Izuku's stomach lurched like he was going to be sick.

Two weeks. Fourteen whole days.

He pressed his free hand to his abdomen, not against the wound but against the hollow weight of time passing through his fingers.

Underneath this shock, a terrible realization struck. It's been two weeks since Tomura. Two weeks had passed since Izuku drove a blade through his brother's heart. Which meant Tomura had been dead in that church, left to rot or possibly found—Izuku didn't even know.

The wrongness of not knowing, made his chest tightened with a quiet, unplaceable guilt.

Katsuki's grip on his hand tightened, as though he could sense it.

The silence stretched until Aizawa cleared his throat. He rose from his corner, his tired eyes scanning the room.

"Alright," he said evenly. "Everyone, I think it's time we get some food in him. He needs his strength back." He glanced at Miruko. "Is he alright to head downstairs for a while?"

"Yeah, he's fine," Miruko replied. "Just no heavy food yet."

"Perfect," Aizawa said, the faintest trace of warmth lifting his tone. "Okay, c'mon. Let's give you the grand tour, Izuku."

The room shifted with movement. Everyone except Katsuki headed to the door, but Izuku stayed still a moment longer. The TV hummed faintly in the background, and though his eyes didn't turn to it, he felt the weight of the date carve into his skull.

When he finally rose, he was helped by Katsuki. The other man kept him steady as he found the slippers next to his hospital bed.

"You sure you're okay?" Katsuki asked. "If you're still too weak, it's fine. You can stay here and I'll bring you the food myself."

Izuku lifted his eyes to him. A faint smile pulled at his lips as the sharp edge of his panic finally softened.

"I'll be alright," he whispered.

As he stood up, he could feel several fractures in his body and stitches in his skin he hadn't noticed before. He must've undergone surgery, and he was thankful for the medical repairs. Together, they moved in slow, uneven steps with Izuku leaning into Katsuki's side for balance. The whole way, his body ached, but Katsuki's arm around him made each step steadier.

Just before they exited into the hallway, Izuku's gaze flickered back to the bedside table.

Arranged in quiet order were fourteen bouquets of yellow daffodils.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Downstairs, the HQ's pseudo-cafeteria buzzed alive with loud chatter. The air smelled faintly of coffee and reheated food. When Izuku entered with Katsuki's arm still around him, a wave of whispers seemed to follow.

Dozens of agents in black suits glanced up from their meals. Conversations dipped into hushed tones and all eyes wandered towards them, then flicked away again, but not fast enough to hide the curiosity.

Izuku's pulse jumped. He felt oddly exposed, like someone who'd stumbled back into the world after crossing over. Katsuki's hand stayed steady at his waist, guiding him through the crowd. They joined the others at a long table near the back, where food was already good to go.

The chatter of the room rose again as trays were passed around. Izuku's stomach growled at the sight of warm food and coffee.

As they settled in, the familiar rhythm of clinking utensils and laughter filled the table. Izuku felt something resembling normalcy as he dug in, ignoring his shaking hands. He watched as Denki teased Shinsou and Aizawa pretended not to notice Monoma's snide comments to Katsuki while drinking his tea.

Izuku smiled faintly at the group.

“Thank you all again,” he said quietly, his voice trembling a little.

“It’s no problem,” Monoma replied immediately, waving him off. “You scared the shit out of us, though.”

“Seriously,” Sero added with a smirk. “Neither of you are allowed to die anymore. It’s annoying.”

They all laughed—but Izuku didn’t. His smile wavered, then broke. The weight he’d been holding in his chest came loose all at once, and tears started spilling down his face. His hands shook where they rested in his lap. He couldn’t believe that all this time, Katsuki had been alive, and now his brother was the one who was gone.

Then, softly, Aizawa spoke. “Izuku,” he whispered. “I need to ask you something.”

Izuku blinked, looking up at him through his tears. “Of course. Anything.”

Aizawa seemed hesitant, his eyes flitted to Katsuki. Then he looked back at Izuku with a more concerned expression.

“Why did you poison the cake at the wedding?”

Izuku looked down, feeling boundless shame.

“I…I thought you were all dead and it was my fault,” he confessed quietly. He glanced at each of them, and the guilt from before came in, reminding him of all the pain he’d suffocated in for weeks. “Watching my brother bury Katsuki alive killed something inside of me. Then I heard the guards confirm he was dead.”

He took a pause, and Katsuki reached back over to hold his hand.

“They said they found him rotting away in the coffin,” Izuku explained. “I-I never felt anything like I felt after that. I spiraled down until I couldn’t…I couldn’t see the future anymore. It felt like I was sinking into misery, and the only way to make what happened feel just was to bring them down into the darkness with me.”

Aizawa’s gaze softened.

“Revenge doesn’t bring peace,” he said, lecturing kindly. “It only keeps the wound open. You can’t build a life on hate, Izuku. You’ll drown in it.”

Izuku nodded weakly. “I know,” he whispered, eyes still glassy. “I see that now.”

“Unfortunately, I think the damage has been done,” Aizawa muttered. “I’ve been keeping a pulse check on the underground in Tokyo, and it seems like it’s pretty much disorganized havoc.”

Izuku wearily glanced up. “Really?”

“Yeah. Without Chisaki Kai and his parents, the Shie Hassaikai officially disbanded. The original Yakuza families are trying to make power grabs all over the place—but there are some Chisaki loyalists who are still looking for blood.”

“That makes sense,” Izuku exhaled heavily. “The Chisakis have long memories.”

“They do, sadly,” Aizawa agreed. “And as more bodies get identified, it seems like those Chisaki loyalists are noticing you and your brother, Tomura, are unaccounted for. On top of that, there’s rumors circulating about Bakugou being back from the dead after you two ran through the crowds in Hadeus.”

Izuku dropped his head.

It wasn’t as bad as before—but still not great.

“I’m sorry,” Izuku hissed. He clenched his teeth angry at himself. “I’m *so* sorry for all of this. I don’t know what else to do now that we missed Nana’s window, I…” He trailed off, shoulders sinking. “I don’t think it’s safe for us to stay in Japan for too long, but I don’t know how we can get out without someone like Nana’s help. Maybe we can wait for her to open again in a couple of months—but that backfired last time.”

For a moment, no one responded.

Then Denki leaned forward, grinning. “Who said Nana’s window is closed?”

Izuku lifted his head, confused. His eyes darted from face to face for what the joke was. But no one was laughing or teasing. Shinsou gave him a small, knowing smile, and even Monoma’s usual smugness softened into kindness.

Katsuki reached over and squeezed his shoulders, drawing his attention. Beautiful scarlet eyes gazed into him with the most hopeful, lovely expression of devotion.

“She’s still an option now, Izuku.” Katsuki said.

Izuku gaped, and disbelief flooded his features. “Wh-What?”

Katsuki’s thumb began brushing gently against Izuku’s collarbone.

“She said she’d wait for you,” he explained. “Her apprentice, Yagi, has been running her operation in the meantime, while she waited until you were ready to come back.”

Izuku’s breath skipped. He covered his mouth with one trembling hand, and new tears welled up.

“She waited?” he whispered.

“Yeah,” Katsuki repeated, grin widening. “She never stopped.”

Izuku broke. The sound that left him was halfway between a laugh and a sob. Katsuki pulled him close and rubbed his back. Around them, the others smiled, and the warmth of their

small circle enveloped him like nothing he's ever felt.

For the first time in what felt like forever, Izuku let himself believe in hope.

He smiled brightly at the love of his life, then slowly Katsuki's smile started to fade. His eyes darted quickly to Monoma, who now was no longer wearing a smile. Izuku caught the exchange, and frowned slightly.

"There's something else," Katsuki said. "It's about your brother."

"What is it?" Izuku asked cautiously.

Katsuki looked at him with cautious gentleness. "…It'll be better if I show you."

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku stared down at Tomura, frozen in time.

The tattoos on his skin looked dull now, faded against skin that no longer held any warmth. But somehow, he looked…peaceful.

Terrifyingly peaceful.

"I figured it was a good idea to bring him back with us," Katsuki explained with his arms crossed. "I wanted you to have the final call of what to do with him."

Izuku simply stared for a long time.

For once, in this state, Tomura looked his age: only thirty. It hit Izuku exactly how young his brother really was this whole time. The shape of his absence pulsed inside his heart. It was crooked, uneven and gutted him out in a way that hurt and relieved him all at once.

Looking at Tomura like this felt like he was losing a weight he'd learned to live with. In a way, he'd miss the weight. It moved like a phantom limb with his body because of how much he'd grown accustomed to it. But ultimately, he couldn't deny he was better off without it—without him. And that's what hurt.

Knowing he was better off without a person he loved for years was a sour pill to swallow.

Yet, Izuku swallowed it whole in that moment.

He reached out and brushed a strand of hair behind Tomura's ear.

Behind him, Katsuki lingered. He didn't make a move, and he stayed entirely respectful. When Izuku finally drew his hand back, Katsuki spoke.

"What do you want to do with him?" His tone was careful. "Anything you want, I can make sure it happens."

Izuku studied Tomura one last time, then exhaled. The breath wavered, but his decision did not.

“Can we cremate him?” He asked. “I’d like to keep his ashes.”

Katsuki nodded once. “Yeah. We can do that.”

Izuku turned towards Katsuki, full of gratitude. His lover wrapped his arm around his shoulders and soothed him. Then, with all the care in the world, Izuku quietly slid the drawer shut.

He let the silence spread throughout the room and into his body too.



The building lights dimmed, leaving everything washed in soft orange. Most of the agents from The Company left out, and without the full bustle of the crowds, Izuku felt the emptiness creep back in.

Everyone from their group began to say their goodbyes. Denki and Sero left first, both giving Izuku a hug and a reassuring grin. Aizawa followed soon after, muttering something about needing to run an errand or two. Next, Shinsou and Monoma departed. They both waved, giving half grins to Izuku and Katsuki.

Once everyone was gone, Miruko stayed behind a little longer. She plopped a small pharmacy’s worth of pill bottles into Izuku’s bed side table.

“Alrighty,” she said briskly, sorting them into a neat row on Izuku’s tray table. “These three are antibiotics. Take one of each every morning and night. And this one’s for pain. Don’t overdo it, got it?”

Izuku nodded weakly. “Got it.”

“And you,” she turned to Katsuki. “Make sure he eats before he takes the heavy ones. If he starts getting dizzy, make him sit down. And he’ll also probably get a few nightmares, so wake him up if he starts thrashing.”

“I got it,” Katsuki parroted.

Miruko eyed them both for a moment, then scowled.

“No funny business either,” she lectured while grabbing for her coat. “Try to *actually* rest for once.”

They exchanged quiet thanks as she left. Her footsteps faded down the hall, and suddenly it was just them standing in the private hospital room. The hum of the lights seemed louder now, amplified faintly by the walls.

“You should shower,” Katsuki suggested, nodding toward the bathroom. “You’ll feel better once you’ve cleaned off a bit more.”

Izuku gave a nod. “That sounds like a great idea.”

“Do you need any help?” Katsuki asked.

Izuku shook his head. “I’ll be okay, Kacchan. It’s just a shower.”

“Alright,” Katsuki replied, not fully convinced. “I’ll make the bed. If you change your mind, give me a holler, okay?”

“Okay.” Izuku smiled.

He walked toward the bathroom, stiff but steady. He exhaled softly and stripped off the hospital gown.

When he turned on the shower and stepped beneath the stream, the first rush of heat drew an exhausted sigh from him. The steam rose, fogging the mirror and blurring the tiled walls into soft shapes. At first, the pressure against his body stripped a layer of heaviness off his shoulders. He could feel his limbs relax under the heat as the aches in his muscles dulled for a moment.

But as he reached for the soap, a different kind of ache crept in.

It slowly eased inside like an unsuspected guest. He blinked, surprised at how heavy his arms suddenly felt. Pulling himself back, he tried to reach for the soap again. But was stopped by the onslaught of vivid memories that came in full force.

Particularly Tomura’s blood-covered, dying face.

Izuku’s chest weighed down as if a thousand ruined hearts resided inside of him. He tried to carry them all, but he was only one man—and soon, he was too tired to lift his hands. Surrendering himself, he leaned backwards and rested against the cold tile. A small break couldn’t hurt, he convinced himself. His arms shook as he tried to reach for the soap again, but the motion slowed and then steadily lost all purpose.

When the poignant weight on his shoulders became too much, he sank to the floor of the shower, curling in on himself as the water cascaded over him. Izuku tried to make himself stand up, but he was too heavy from the sadness sitting at the bottom of his being.

He didn’t know how long he stayed there. The water running over his skin went from hot to lukewarm as his mind looped the memory of Tomura dying over and over.

“Izuku?” Katsuki called. “Izuku, you good in there?”

Izuku tried to respond. But he couldn’t.

The door creaked open, and a rush of steam spilled into the cooler air beyond. Katsuki’s steps were careful, and his breath caught when he saw the other man in the shower.

“Shit,” Katsuki whispered. “Izuku…”

Izuku sat slumped against the wall, water running down his hair, his face streaked with tears that wouldn’t stop.

Katsuki’s expression twisted with pain, worry, and love. Without another word, he stripped off his shirt, his pants, and everything. He stepped into the shower fully draped in concern, and the moment he crouched beside him, Izuku wrapped his arms around him and sobbed.

Katsuki lifted him up carefully, his chest warm even under the water. Izuku’s body quaked against him, his hands clutching at Katsuki’s shoulders as if afraid he might disappear on him again.

“I’ve got you,” Katsuki murmured against his temple.

Izuku nodded weakly, pressing his face into the curve of Katsuki’s chest. The water hit Katsuki’s back and streamed down their joined bodies, tracing every scar.

Katsuki reached for the soap. “Let me help you, okay?”

Izuku didn’t answer, but he didn’t resist either.

He stayed pressed against him, eyes closed, breathing in sync with his lover. Katsuki gingerly ran his soapy hands down Izuku’s arms, over his shoulders, and through his matted hair. Every movement was filled with the kind of tenderness that didn’t need words.

The suds shifted from gray to pale blue, washing away the dirt and dried blood that clung to Izuku’s skin. The grief, though, refused to be rinsed off. It lingered deep inside him, heavy but dulled. The pain softened a touch through the steady rhythm of Katsuki’s palms.

By the time the water finally shifted to freezing, Izuku’s body was trembling, but his breathing steadied. Katsuki turned off the tap and just held him, water dripping from both of them. Izuku closed his eyes and pressed his head further inside Katsuki’s beating heart.

“Sorry,” Izuku whispered shamefully. “I…I thought I could.”

“It’s fine,” Katsuki replied. “I should’ve known. You’re always trying to do things on your own. But I’m here now, alright? You never have to do the hard shit alone. Not anymore.”

They didn’t move, and together they stayed in the moment as the steam curled around them in thick, hazy clouds. Izuku’s shoulders slumped as the last droplets ran down his skin. His body felt lighter than before, but when Katsuki reached for a towel and began gently rubbing him dry, he didn’t pull away.

His lover worked in silence, every motion careful and patient.

“Hey,” Katsuki murmured, voice low and warm against the fog. “You’re safe, okay?”

Izuku only nodded. His eyes were distant, and his lashes were wet. He dried him off first with slow, tender movements. He dabbed at the bruises along Izuku’s ribs, wiped the lingering

soap from his arms, then moved up to his face, brushing away stray droplets that clung to his cheeks.

When he reached Izuku's hair, he paused. Then, with both hands, he ruffled through the damp curls until they sprang up wildly.

A startled laugh slipped from Izuku before he could stop it. Katsuki's mouth curved, and his own laughter followed, loud and unguarded.

Their eyes met in the mirror across the room. Izuku nearly flinched at his reflection—his curls were puffed into an absurd halo and his nose was pink from crying. Katsuki guided him closer, water still trailing onto the floor from their skin. More laughter bloomed between them, fragile but real.

"Looks good on you," Katsuki said, meeting his gaze.

Izuku smiled through his sniffling. "You're lying."

"Maybe," Katsuki grinned. "But it makes you look like a real damn nerd."

Izuku laughed faintly and found his strength again to finish drying off. When they both finished, they made their way back to the room together, towels wrapped around their waists. The dim light of the bedside lamp washed everything in gold.

Two pairs of clean sleepwear lay neatly on the bed, making Izuku smile. Katsuki dressed first, his movements quiet and efficient, then he turned to help Izuku. With a tired smile, he lifted the shirt and guided it over Izuku's shoulders. Along the way, his knuckles grazed damp skin in passing. The touch was featherlight, but it sent a familiar ripple through Izuku all the same. Katsuki's fingers lingered for a heartbeat too long, smoothing wrinkles that didn't exist.

"Perfect," Katsuki said quietly. "Nice and cozy, like you should be."

There was so much affection in his voice it made Izuku's heart tighten.

When they finally climbed into their combined beds, the air was thick with exhaustion. Izuku sank against Katsuki's chest, curling instinctively into the warmth. Like clockwork, his lover's arms encircled him, and a hand found the small of his back. Izuku closed his eyes, easing into how familiar this felt. He basked in the feeling of being held, it was revitalizing to be in Katsuki's embrace after mourning for so long.

"…I'm sorry you had to be the one to kill your brother, Izuku."

The words came softly, but their weight was brutal.

Izuku went entirely still.

Without his permission, his mind unraveled the tangled mess of choices that led to that moment. He tried to find a thread that would have brought them down a different path.

Maybe one that allowed him, Katsuki, and his brother all alive. But in every path he followed, it all led to the same cruel ending.

Because like every Viper, Tomura followed his resolve all the way to the bitter end.

It was inevitable, one of them was going to die. That much, Izuku was certain. Because Tomura had been killing him slowly for years. He did it with every punishment, every twisted act of control, and every lesson in cruelty that was aimed to annihilate his emotions until there was nothing left. Izuku lived inside Tomura's cage for so long that taking his life felt like the only way to be free.

If Katsuki hadn't come when he did, Izuku would be dead.

But against all odds, Katsuki had. And Tomura would and could never let him go.

He held his lover tighter, fingers sinking into his shirt as if to hold himself to reality.

"He didn't give us much of a choice," Izuku whispered sourly.

"But still." Katsuki caressed him lightly. "That's hard to carry. If there's anything I can do to help you shoulder that, let me know, alright?"

"Just your being here is enough, Kacchan."

For a while, neither of them spoke.

Izuku retraced everything from the gravesite to now. After so much mourning, his mind still struggled to process the truth that somehow Tomura was the dead one—not Katsuki.

Almost afraid that this reality would disappear if he didn't confirm it, he slipped a trembling hand beneath Katsuki's shirt. His fingertips grazed over warm skin, searching for the gunshot, until they found it. The scar was raised, uneven, and ugly in its permanence.

Izuku's fingers curled against the wound, and his face crumbled.

"I—I really thought you were gone," he whispered.

Katsuki's fingers tightened on his back. "I'm sorry. I'll never scare you like that ever again."

"How did you…" Izuku trailed off, unsure if he could finish the sentence. He blinked back several tears, trying to hold himself together. "Several Vipers said you drowned in your own blood. They—they saw your body."

Katsuki pulled back just enough to see Izuku's face. He reached up and used his thumb to brush away the stray tear that clung stubbornly to the corner of Izuku's eye.

"I might've punched my way out and got to a phone," Katsuki said, his mouth curled into a faint, lopsided smile. "I called Aizawa, and they staged the whole scene to make it look like I never made it out."

Izuku's eyes widened. "You broke out? With your *hands*?"

"Yeah," Katsuki scoffed lightly. "Not exactly unscathed, I've got some nerve damage, and I can't fully feel my knuckles anymore." His gaze flickered down to his battered hands. "I…I don't know what came over me. But the thought of getting back to you was enough to get me moving. I couldn't let you be trapped there."

Izuku's eyes watered again, but this time not from sadness.

This time it was of pure, intense admiration for Katsuki. He looked at the other man in the dim light and saw something truly beautiful. He stared at the person who clawed his way from the bottom in a world that always tried to bury him alive. Not only did he endure all his hardship, he'd managed to come out on the other side stronger than anyone Izuku ever knew.

"You're so amazing, Kacchan," Izuku said.

But then Katsuki's face dropped. His eyes skirted off to the side as though the words hurt him to hear. And when he met Izuku's gaze again. He retracted his hand as though he didn't deserve to touch him. He sat up slightly and gazed at Izuku, full of regret.

"…I'm not," Katsuki whispered painfully.

Izuku frowned immediately. He sat up too, confused. "Huh? What do you mean? You're one of the most incredible people I've ever known."

Katsuki looked away. His face screwed in unfiltered hurt. "I—I'm so fucking sorry about making that deal with your brother."

Izuku's eyes softened.

Ah. This is what was weighing on Katsuki.

"I should've *never* done that," Katsuki went on. "I was so angry back then. And I didn't have the full picture, but when I finally did, I realized how big of a mistake I'd made—but I couldn't come to terms with how to tell you—"

Izuku stopped him by threading their fingers together. "I get why you did it. It's okay."

"But it's not okay," Katsuki shot back instantly. He shook his head as remorse filled his eyes. "I was so angry and hurt that I let my need for revenge against Chisaki overshadow how much I—" His breath hitched. "—how much I love you."

Katsuki drew in a ragged breath and let out a harrowing groan, pressing his palms to his eyes for a moment before lowering them.

"And I should've told you what I did sooner," he muttered hoarsely. "I understand now why you couldn't tell me about my mom when you found out. You didn't want to hurt me…just like I didn't want to hurt you."

Izuku's lips turned up into a small, ironic smile. "I guess we just love each other a little too much, huh? We're both afraid of hurting the other."

Katsuki nodded solemnly. "Yeah."

After a beat, he reached out and took Izuku's hands into his own. His thumbs brushed over the new scars.

"But we can't do that anymore," Katsuki said. "If we really love each other, then we can't keep holding back out of fear. I've learned my damn lesson. From now on, I'll tell you *everything*—no matter how ugly or hard it is. You deserve honesty, even when it hurts."

Izuku's throat tightened as he squeezed Katsuki's hands back.

"I agree," he replied with a smile. "And there's nothing you could ever tell me that would make me love you less. Not after everything we've gone through."

Katsuki's expression softened. "Same here."

"Is there anything else I should know about? I think we've told each other just about everything now."

Katsuki hesitated. His gaze drifted off to the side, lips pursing as though debating whether to speak.

"…I guess there is *one* thing," Katsuki confessed.

Izuku frowned, taken aback. "What is it?"

Katsuki rubbed at the back of his neck, clearly guilty. "I, uh…put a tracker in your ring."

For a beat, Izuku only stared at him. Then he tilted his head and frowned deeper. He reached for the chain around his neck and held the small ring up.

"The wedding ring?" he clarified, pointing to it. "This one?"

Katsuki winced.

"Yeah." He let out a sheepish groan and scratched behind his head. "The night we got separated, I couldn't sleep. I kept thinking about what might happen if something went wrong and we got split up. You were out cold, so I, uh, welded a tiny tracker inside the band. That's…how we were able to find you. I meant to tell you after, but then the cabin got raided and everything went to shit."

Izuku stared at the ring again and then back at Katsuki—who was now visibly squirming.

"Sorry," Katsuki muttered, shoulders slumping. "I know it's creepy. We can take it out tomorrow—"

"—Lets keep it," Izuku interrupted quickly.

Katsuki startled as Izuku leaned in and caught his wrists. Izuku exploded into a brilliant, genuine smile that warmed every inch of the room.

“I think that’s the most romantic thing I’ve *ever* heard,” Izuku said, voice full of laughter. “You really made sure you could always come back to me, huh?”

Katsuki gawked, utterly dumbfounded. Then his face flushed, ears turning red as a shy grin tugged at the corner of his mouth.

“You’re such a weirdo,” Katsuki chuckled. “But we’ll only keep it if I put one in mine too. We can make it square.”

“I like the sound of that,” Izuku said with a smile.

Their eyes met, and wordless forgiveness passed between them. It was bright, and felt like home. All the cards were finally laid out, and Izuku accepted every single one. His gaze dropped to Katsuki’s hands, and a trembling laugh escaped him when he noticed the emerald eternity band was still glinting there.

His own chest rose and fell unevenly, intense emotions riling up like waves crashing against the shore of his heart.

As if he could read his mind, Katsuki reached forward. His fingers brushed against Izuku’s collarbone as he unclasped the chain resting there. He slipped the wedding ring free and it gleamed in the dim light.

With no hesitation, Izuku lifted his shaky hand. Katsuki steadied him, and he slid the eternity ring back onto its rightful place.

It settled perfectly, as if it never left.

“I hope this is the last time I have to put a ring on your finger,” Katsuki mumbled cheekily but tenderly.

Izuku chuckled. “Don’t worry. I’m never taking it off again.”

Their hearts seemed to move in sync.

At the same time, they leaned in. Their foreheads brushed and their noses touched lightly. In the narrow sliver of air they shared, their breaths tangled. Izuku felt the temperature under his skin spike.

Katsuki’s eyes lowered down to Izuku’s softly parted lips—and a single pull drew them together at once.

They met in a kiss, and every inch of Izuku’s body flushed warm. It felt exactly like a homecoming. Imaginary fireworks went off in Izuku’s head as he leaned into his lover. They started tender and slow, but deepened instantly. It was languid but laced with yearning that ached with relief of the other person being alive.

Katsuki's hand slid to the back of Izuku's neck, and his fingers threaded through his damp curls. He guided Izuku closer until their chests were flush together. Izuku's hands moved on their own too. He gripped Katsuki and pulled him closer, like he couldn't stand the idea of distance between them any longer.

As they lost themselves, all Izuku could think was how happy he was to have Katsuki back.Katsuki's thumb brushed along Izuku's jaw before tilting his chin up to take him deeper. Izuku's lips parted willingly, and Katsuki's mouth claimed him with the same ferocity Izuku missed more than oxygen.

By the time they sank back into the bed, they were entirely tangled together in the soft glow of the lamp.

Katsuki pulled the covers on top of them and tucked them under their chins.

With a light giggle, Izuku rested his fingers against Katsuki's cheek. His thumb traced the edge of a smile neither of them could quite suppress.

"I don't think I ever want to be apart from you again," Izuku whispered into the kiss.

"Good, because neither do I," Katsuki replied. "Not ever."

"Does this mean we're technically fiancés now?" Izuku grinned. "Since, y'know."

"Yeah. I guess we're fiancés. Because I'm going to marry you again the first chance we get."

Several more tiny, drowsy kisses passed between them. Izuku let out another soft laugh, and Katsuki responded with a quiet chuckle against his lips. Their chests touched, and Izuku counted each heartbeat as proof of life, existence, and endurance.

Somehow, despite all odds, he and Katsuki were proof that all his hopeless romantic beliefs were right: love did somehow conquer all. It defied death and survived the unimaginable.

The light in Izuku's eyes returned, resurrected by the love of his life—his true husband.

Chapter End Notes

Time for some well needed TLC! Everything is coming down officially, and the next few chapters are significantly less stressful and just the comfort part of the hurt/and comfort now ^^

Thank you guys so much for reading! <3 Lemme know your thoughts

Chapter 50: Affecttuoso

Chapter Summary

> Affettuoso (style indicator) — To play an instrument with affection, tenderness, and emotion.

Chapter Notes

> Hellooooo! Welcome back to this choo-choo train :') This chapter is a sweet one. No big angst surprises, just sweet fluff. It's been nice writing these last few chapters and just having the chapters enjoy their time together without all the major threats looming. I hope you like!
>
> **Warnings: Adult scenes and themes**

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 50 — Affecttuoso

.

.

.

Katsuki laid awake in the dark, staring up at the ceiling.

He couldn’t sleep well. He tried, but it was pretty damn hard. The faint hum of the night pressed against the walls as his eyes drifted to the clock. It was some indecent hour where even the silence seemed restless.

He exhaled tiredly and turned onto his side.

Beside him, Izuku slept soundly. He had his face half buried in the fluffy pillow, breathing unevenly, which made Katsuki listen a little too closely. From the sound alone, it was apparent Izuku’s lungs weren’t fully recovered. He made sharp inhales and coughed occasionally as he slept.

With a crestfallen stare, Katsuki reached out and brushed his knuckles along Izuku’s soft cheek. A shitty feeling began eating away at him. He couldn’t shake this unbearable fear that if he blinked too long, Izuku might slip back into a coma—and not come back out.

Right as he was about to force himself to sleep, Izuku twitched.

He paused.

Izuku twitched again. Then again.

At first, it was small. It started out with a faint furrow of his brow, then suddenly it became a tremor on his lips.

Katsuki's attention caught when another sound came: a broken groan, muffled in Izuku's throat. The other man began breathing louder and in a blink, Izuku's body tensed. He tossed violently under the sheets and thrashed his head to the side.

"N-No—" Izuku hissed, and screwed his face in fear. "Get off me—"

"Hey. *Hey*—" Katsuki called, pushing up onto an elbow.

He grabbed Izuku's shoulder and shook him lightly. The smaller man flinched at the touch in his slumber, and Katsuki cursed.

"Wake up," Katsuki said loudly, shaking Izuku's shoulder vigorously. "*Izuku*—wake the hell up."

Izuku gasped as if he'd been drowning, and his eyes flew open. Pure terror flooded his face as his gaze darted around the room.

"Easy," Katsuki said quickly, pulling him close. "It's me."

Izuku looked up at Katsuki with his chest heaving. His wide eyes were full of panic, and Katsuki soothed him the best he could. His hand stroked gently through Izuku's hair while he made steady, peaceful deep breaths for the other man to follow.

"You're okay," Katsuki said. "Just breathe. Take your time."

Gradually, the air between them steadied. Katsuki ran a hand along Izuku's forehead, pushing aside the damp curls.

"You with me?" Katsuki asked.

Izuku nodded, coming down slowly. "Y-Yeah, sorry. I—I thought I was back…I thought I was back with…" Izuku trailed off and blinked hard.

Katsuki's eyes softened. "You thought you were back at the Chisaki estate?"

The silence Izuku gave was enough of an answer.

Gently, Katsuki leaned in and wrapped his arms around the spooked man. He tried his best to offer all he could to counterbalance the remnants of the nightmare. At the thought of what type of disgusting shit must've happened during their separation, his stomach turned. God. He didn't make Chisaki feel enough goddamn pain.

“He’s dead,” Katsuki assured. “That scum can’t touch you ever again. I made *very* sure of that.”

Izuku swallowed hard, still shaking.

“Sorry,” he whispered. “I didn’t mean to wake you.”

“It’s not your fault. Miruko said the medication might cause night terrors.”

“What a terrible side effect,” Izuku grumbled. He groaned and scrubbed his hands down his face. “God. It felt so real.”

“Do you want to talk about what happened there?” Katsuki whispered. “I’m wide awake. Maybe if you work through it, the nightmare won’t return. But if you’re not ready too, that’s also okay.”

Izuku’s mouth parted apprehensively. They both silently assessed the other, and Izuku’s eyes searched Katsuki’s, looking for stability to hold on to in the moment.

“It’s good to talk, right?” Izuku asked wearily. “Even about the uncomfortable things?”

“It is.” Katsuki nodded. “You’re the one who taught me that.”

Izuku smiled weakly. He encircled his arms around Katsuki to calm himself.

“I-I wasn’t tortured,” Izuku began with. “Not in the proper sense of the word, but every inch of their place was covered in gold or jade—and I mean *every* inch. The floors, the walls, and even the paintings.”

He lowered his eyes and Katsuki held him tighter.

“When I arrived, they assessed me like I was another item for their collection,” Izuku said with a simmering disgust. “They put that golden ankle monitor on me and tried to dress me up in gold and jade too. It was so jarring, going from feeling free to being reminded I had been bought. Like I was a possession.”

“You’re *not* a possession, Izuku,” Katsuki hissed. “You’re a person and they all were sick in the head.”

“I know. But Chisaki Kai in particular,” Izuku whispered. “He…he made me keep him company. The first day we spent together—” His throat bobbed. The next words came out small and shameful. “He forced himself on me. He tore my shirt open and told me if I didn’t do what he wanted—” Izuku paused and clutched at his own clothes, as if to protect himself. “He’d make his guards hold me down.”

Katsuki saw red.

God, he should’ve *castrated* that mother fucker.

His jaw clenched so hard he heard his molars grind. “Did he do that?”

Izuku shook his head quickly.

“No. I stopped him,” he said. “I made him think I wanted to save myself for our wedding night. So nothing happened between us. But…” His voice went below a whisper. “I guess I didn’t realize until now how terrified I was of *that*. It always felt looming, as if I had no control over who got my body.”

Silence stretched for long, and Katsuki craved to take all Izuku’s fears in his palms and disintegrate them.

“Every time he pawed at me,” Izuku whispered, voice welling up. “I just kept thinking this was it. This is the moment. I have no say, and he’s going to rape me because he paid Tomura for permission to do so. Before Chisaki, I believed my training made me untouchable. I could break any hand that crossed my boundaries and keep myself protected away from any violations. But with the arrangement—I had my power taken. I guess I feel…weak.”

“*Don’t*,” Katsuki countered. “Don’t you *dare* say that about yourself. He was the weak one.” His thumb brushed the side of Izuku’s face, tracing over the faint scars along his jaw. “You hear me? You’re not weak at all. You’re far from it. Izuku, you’re the strongest person I know.”

Izuku’s lips trembled. “Then why do I feel like I’m not strong at all?”

Katsuki gathered Izuku closer until their foreheads touched, and their breaths mingled in the dark. Izuku looked up, eyes wet and luminous, and Katsuki’s heart broke.

“Because you’re human,” Katsuki said. “We forget a lot of the damn time what we’re capable of. And sometimes you just need to be reminded.” His fingers brushed through Izuku’s hair, down the line of his neck, and stopped above the tattoo on his collar bone. “You’re *strong*, Izuku. You’re stronger than anyone I’ve ever met in my whole life.”

Izuku shivered. Not from fear this time, but from the pure human ache of being seen.

As Katsuki cradled Izuku, he ran his hands up and down the other man’s sides. He tried his best to make him feel soothed and protected.

But all the while, his anger burned in the pit of his throat. It scorched up, and Katsuki felt that destructive urge to make the world burn again. Izuku had been dragged through far too much, and he deeply needed far more than five hundred people dead to pay for what had happened.

Izuku pressed closer, burying his face against the crook of Katsuki’s neck. His breath came out warm and trembling. Katsuki’s touch slowed to soft circles over his back, drawing him down, grounding him in the steady rhythm of contact.

Then, a change happened. It was so small Katsuki thought he’d imagined it.

Izuku’s lips brushed against the base of his throat. Once. Then twice.

Katsuki’s movements stilled.

“I-I want to feel safe,” Izuku whispered desperately. “I miss feeling safe with you.”

Izuku’s breath lingered against his skin, then trailed upward along the line of his neck in a row of kisses. He kept going, trembling the entire way until his lips found the sharp edge of Katsuki’s jaw. Each kiss was full of pleading that awoke heat in Katsuki’s blood. By the time Izuku’s lips reached Katsuki’s mouth, they both were holding each other closer.

For a beat, Izuku hovered there with their breaths catching.

Then he closed the distance. Their lips met, and their troubles seemed to fall away. It was timid at first, testing the waters. Izuku’s leg intertwined with his, and Katsuki welcomed it. Their limbs tangled as the kiss deepened. It grew more and more passionate, but Katsuki couldn’t hide the surprise when the other man blatantly ground down on his thigh.

He broke away out of shock.

Izuku fisted Katsuki’s shirt tighter and their eyes met for a prolonged moment. In the silence, a pretty blush spread across Izuku’s cheeks, nose and ears. He dug his gaze into Katsuki with a fixed resolve.

“Can you make me feel safe again?” Izuku breathed, voice barely there. “Please?”

Katsuki’s heart slammed. “…Are you sure?”

He wanted to. He wanted to *so* damn badly. It’d be satisfying to wipe away any traces of touch on Izuku’s skin that didn’t belong to him. He’d make damn sure Izuku felt heard and cared for.

“Yes.” Izuku’s eyes glistened in the moonlight. “I missed you.”

Katsuki leaned in, apprehensive at first. Then Izuku tilted just enough for their lips to find each other. The kiss was soft, cautious, but beneath it ran the undercurrent of yearning. Izuku’s hand slid underneath the fabric of Katsuki’s shirt. He dragged his unsteady fingers across the muscles until he found the bullet wound.

“Does it hurt?” Izuku whispered during their kiss.

Katsuki shook his head. “Not when you touch it.”

Izuku caressed the wound tenderly.

That simple gesture made Katsuki decide not to rush it. He could gauge exactly what Izuku was asking for, and it wasn’t simply intimacy. Izuku wanted reassurance that he had control of what happened to his body.

Carefully, Katsuki’s thumb traced slow, grounding circles against Izuku’s pulse in his neck.

Instantly, Izuku shuddered under the touch and opened himself up more. Katsuki deepened the kiss by a breath, and his hand cupped Izuku’s jaw. Then, the warmth between them

shifted. The tentative melancholy they were holding on to drifted into love so potent it felt alive.

When they finally pulled back, their foreheads were still touching. Katsuki sat up and curled his finger for Izuku to come up with him. Slowly, Izuku followed. The blanket fell away, exposing both of their bodies in the darkroom. In the low light, the only thing Katsuki could see was Izuku's shining eyes.

"Lift your arms," Katsuki instructed.

Izuku obeyed, and Katsuki peeled his shirt away.

As he gazed at all of Izuku's fresh scars, his fiancé reached for him too. Small hands caught the hem of the sleep shirt and tugged. Without breaking eye contact, Izuku hoisted up Katsuki's shirt, and lifted it over his head as well.

He watched as Izuku's beautiful eyes darted all over his chest. They went scar to scar, cataloging all the new bruises and cuts that decorated him. Katsuki proudly wore each one, because every injury he sustained was all in the name of getting Izuku back.

Following the need to be closer, he wrapped his arms around Izuku. He dragged his fiancé towards him with a single movement, pressing their chests together. They gazed at each other as Katsuki steered Izuku's legs. He spread them wide and slid the smaller man onto his lap.

"Is this okay?" Katsuki asked.

Izuku nodded, and his eyes set at half mast.

They leaned in again. The kiss was softer now, unhurried but passionate all the same. Their mouths moved in a steady rhythm. Give and take. Push and pull.

Warmth mingled until it was impossible to tell where one of them ended, and the other began. His fingers traced down Izuku's sides, earning a sharp inhale against his lips. Izuku's arms tightened around his neck. At that moment, they dissolved into each other completely.

"Where did he touch you?" Katsuki demanded.

Izuku pulled back. A moment of hesitation passed, but he raised his hand.

"Right here." He touched his hair and slowly trailed his fingers down to his cheek then to his chin. "And here." He dragged his hand down his neck, to his collarbone, and to the center of his chest. Izuku let out a shaky, distressed breath. "…And here."

Katsuki followed the trail with his lips.

He nipped at each place, making sure to override any feeling of Chisaki from Izuku's skin. He replaced it all with feathery touches of love, devotion and respect. As he worked his way down, his fiancée exhaled all the way. Izuku relaxed into him, and closed his eyes as he gave into the touch.

“Thank you,” Izuku breathed. His fingers laced through Katsuki’s locks. “Thank you, Kacchan. I don’t want anyone to touch me like this besides you.”

Katsuki kissed Izuku’s sternum. “No one but me?”

Izuku nodded. “Yeah. No one else.”

“Okay,” Katsuki rasped, voice coarse as his lips hovered over Izuku’s jaw. “I promise. I’ll make sure I’m the only one who gets to touch you like this,” he murmured. His warm breath ghosted against Izuku’s skin as he drifted lower, kissing the hollow between his collarbones. “I’ll be the only one who gets to hear you fall apart.”

Katsuki’s hand tightened at the nape of Izuku’s neck, firm enough to draw a soft, broken sound from him. His fiancé’s eyes fluttered shut, breath stuttering as Katsuki’s mouth charted a tedious path lower. His lips grazed every inch of Izuku’s skin like he knew it by heart.

“And I’ll make damn sure I’m your one and only, Izuku.”

Izuku exhaled shakily, head tipping back as if in surrender. His curls spilled with the motion. He gave himself over completely to the only man he’d ever trust to take him apart like this.

Katsuki’s gaze flicked upward. His breath caught at the sight of Izuku’s throat bared to him, the elegant curve of it laid open in latent offering.

He pressed several open mouth kisses along Izuku’s chest as he carefully laid them back down. He watched, full of wonderment, as Izuku’s hair spread across the pillowcase. Bright green eyes were tracking him, dilated all the way in the deep dark.

Slowly, he leaned up and settled between Izuku’s thighs. He pushed their pelvises together as Izuku opened his legs further. They both looked down at where their hips were joined, and the subtle hardness in both of their pants poked through.

Katsuki gave an experimental roll, and Izuku responded instantly. His damn gorgeous fiancé shuddered and ground his hips back. He did it again, drawing another soft whine from those lips he loved to kiss. He closed the distance between them as he kept going, drawing out more and more reedy sounds from Izuku.

“Please,” Izuku called breathlessly. “Make me cum.”

“Plannin’ on it,” Katsuki rasped back.

Katsuki’s powerful arms locked around Izuku’s waist, yanking him flush against his chest in a crushing embrace. He crashed their mouths together in a fierce kiss, devouring him with a raw hunger that screamed *I fucking missed you.*

Izuku arched up, his hips bucked into Katsuki’s with urgent need. He ground their erections together through the thin fabric of their pants. Katsuki’s tongue plunged deep into Izuku’s mouth, tasting the sweet desperation on his tongue. He swirled and sucked until Izuku wept against him. The vibration of that needy sound shot straight down to Katsuki’s groin.

He rolled his hips harder, pressing their rigid lengths firmly against each other. The friction sent glints of pleasure jolting through both of them. Izuku's moan vibrated louder this time, a broken, breathy cry that Katsuki drank in like air.

His hands slid down to grip Izuku's ass and pull him even closer. He thrusted again, deliberate and rough, dragging their cocks in a teasing rhythm that pulled out gasp after gasp from Izuku's swollen lips. The heat built to an inferno as they lost themselves in the frantic grind, every rock of their bodies fueling their desire.

Izuku gasped into their interlocked mouths as the friction surged between them. His fingers dug into Katsuki's back and scraped down the hills of his muscles as he arched up. Katsuki moved more vigorously, pressing pleasure into every inch of Izuku's body. Sparks of tantalizing static rolled up his back as Izuku locked his legs around his waist and pressed their cocks perfectly together.

Katsuki's eyes darkened with deep need as he shoved two thick fingers against Izuku's soft, parted lips.

"Get 'em soaked for me," he commanded.

Izuku's mouth fell open eagerly, no resistance in his hazy gaze. He drew the fingers inside with a wet, slurping pull, his tongue curling around them like he was starving for it. Saliva glistened as he bobbed his head, hollowing his cheeks to suck harder, coating every inch.

"Shit," Katsuki rasped. His breath hitching at the obscene sight.

Izuku's lips stretched around his digits, tongue laving greedily with eyes half-lidded in submission. Izuku's hand clamped onto Katsuki's wrist, guiding the fingers deeper, fucking his own mouth with them in slow, deliberate strokes that mimicked what they both craved lower down.

Those viridian eyes fluttered open fully, locking onto Katsuki's with a smoldering intensity that hit like a punch to the gut. Katsuki's cock throbbed painfully in his pants, straining against the fabric as he watched, mesmerized by the way Izuku's throat worked around his knuckles.

A low, primal groan tore from Katsuki's chest at that heated stare. His free hand dug into Izuku's hip to yank him impossibly closer.

"I only want you too, darling," he murmured, voice husky and edged with desperation.

He thrust his hips forward, grinding his rigid erection against Izuku's with intense force. He dragged his fingers sensually over Izuku's velvety tongue, feeling the hot, slippery slide.

"You're the only one I wanna kiss and taste every inch of." He circled his hips in a teasing grind, their cocks rubbing together through the barriers, friction building fever that made sweat bead on their skin. Katsuki pushed his fingers deeper, bumping the back of Izuku's throat, making him gag softly around them. "And you're the only man who can drive me crazy."

Izuku's body ignited at the words. His cock twitched violently in his pants, a wet spot blooming from the pre-cum leaking steadily. His toes curled tight, back arching off the surface beneath him as a muffled moan vibrated around Katsuki's fingers, the sound lewd and needy. He spread his thighs wide in invitation, knees falling open to cradle Katsuki between them.

Katsuki pulled his fingers back, cursing how well Izuku prepped them.

He leaned back on his hunches, and without a single moment of hesitation, Izuku twisted around. He rolled onto his stomach before pushing up onto all fours. His forehead pressed into the pillow, cheeks aflame with a red blush that crept down his neck as he arched his back.

Katsuki's eyes darkened.

Emboldened by the haze of passion, Izuku reached back with shaky hands. His fingers hooked into the waistband of his pants, tugging them down inch by torturous inch. The fabric dragged over his hips and pulled away from his skin. He shoved them lower, past the swell of his backside and down his thighs until they bunched at his knees, trapping his legs slightly and leaving him utterly bare.

His cock hung heavy between his legs, hard and dripping pre-cum onto the sheets below.

Katsuki's gaze turned molten, pupils blown wide as he stared at the curve of Izuku's spine, the way his cheeks parted just enough to tease the tight entrance between them. His own cock strained against his pants, the ache in his balls intensifying at the vulnerability.

He watched the cool air hit Izuku's heated skin, making him shiver. But his fiancé held the pose: ass up and head down while his heart pounded.

Something about it scratched at the back of Katsuki's mind. The position left Izuku so damn vulnerable—and it made Katsuki ache. Even after everything, Izuku was ready to give it all up to him again and again. It twisted Katsuki's gut with a fierce, protective anguish. His hands itched to claim and cherish.

"Izuku," Katsuki breathed out, heart twisting. His palm slid up Izuku's thigh, thumb brushing the sensitive inner skin. "You trust me so damn much."

Izuku lifted his head just enough to glance back, his gaze softening through the haze of desire.

"Of course I do," Izuku murmured huskily. "You're the only one who's ever made me feel safe in my skin."

Katsuki's jaw ticked as he swallowed thickly, emotion surging hot behind his eyes. He traced the hills of Izuku's spine with his fingertips, feeling the rapid flutter of his pulse.

"You think too highly of me."

“No,” Izuku countered gently. “I see you, Kacchan—all of you. I see the fire inside of you and the fight in your heart that will never go out. But most of all, I see your fierce need to protect the people you love. You’re the only person I’d ever give myself up to like this.”

Katsuki soothed small, steady circles on the small of Izuku’s back. “You’re gonna ruin me, you know that?”

Izuku smiled faintly, dilated eyes growing further. “Then let me.”

A flood of emotion rose inside him, and he leaned down.

At this angle, he could see Izuku’s delicate entrance. He teased the sensitive skin before pressing his two spit-drenched digits right against that tight rim.

He massaged in slow, firm circles. The wet tips of his pads glided, coaxing it to relax and part under the pressure. Izuku sighed tenderly, pushing back into the touch. His hole yielded as Katsuki’s fingers delved shallowly, rubbing and probing with deliberate strokes that built fresh slickness and heat.

“You’re always so beautiful back here,” Katsuki said. “I’m the luckiest man in the world.”

His rough fingers circled Izuku’s tight hole until it gave just enough for the tip of his finger to breach it.

Izuku groaned at the friction. His body tensed beneath Katsuki on the rumpled sheets, but Katsuki didn’t pause. He pressed deeper, crooking his finger to stroke that perfectly sensitive spot inside his future husband. Izuku’s moans hitched and he arched more, spreading himself wide for Katsuki to see.

“Darling,” Katsuki growled. He leaned over Izuku’s body and his breath scorched against Izuku’s skin. “You look so damn *fuckable* right now. I should’ve gotten lube.”

Izuku tried to respond, but all that came out was more moans. The sound turned high and fractured as his back arched off the bed.

Waves of gratification crashed through both of them, and Katsuki drank in the sight of Izuku going absolutely crazy under his touch. His future husband’s hips jerked, shook, and his thighs trembled. Freckles stood out against his flushed honey kissed skin while Katsuki observed every quiver.

Gingerly, he introduced a second finger. He stretched Izuku further, scissoring him to widen the passage, all while delivering more pleasure-filled pushes against Izuku’s sweet spot. Izuku’s body jerked, and he sang a sweet keen that hit right against Katsuki’s ego.

“Yeah, that’s it—moan for your *fiancé*,” he teased.

The filthy words drew a whimper from Izuku. His cock twitched, dribbling pre-cum onto the fabric below.

Katsuki leaned in, blond strands brushing his forehead. He got a good look at Izuku's sweet little hole and groaned under his breath. His hunger surged like a wildfire as he dove in without restraint.

He flattened his tongue broad and wet over the tight rim of Izuku's hole, lapping firmly at the entrance while his fingers curled to press relentlessly against Izuku's prostate. The gland swelled under his assault, swollen and sensitive. Katsuki ruthlessly fucked his fingers in and out with steady, forceful thrusts, each plunge hitting that spot dead-on to wring out sparks of electric pleasure.

Izuku shattered with a crude cry. His back bowed, spine arching in a desperate curve as the dual sensations overwhelmed him. His thighs quivered uncontrollably, muscles locking and releasing in rhythmic spasms. He shoved his ass back against Katsuki's mouth and hand, chasing the burn.

Katsuki growled low in his throat, the vibration rumbling directly into Izuku's sensitive flesh, making the smaller man quiver brokenly. He pulled his fingers out just enough to let his tongue take over, spearing in with quick, insistent licks that teased the rim before pushing past it.

His free hand gripped Izuku's hip hard, nails digging in to hold him in place as he moaned openly, the sound muffled against the twitching opening. He swirled his tongue in steady circles, laving every inch he could reach to make obscene, slurping noises that filled the room.

But he didn't abandon Izuku's sweet spot. Katsuki slid his fingers back in alongside his tongue for a moment. The stretch made Izuku gasp and clench before he crooked them again. He massaged Izuku's prostate with precise, grinding pressure, fucking into it over and over until his sweet darling's cock leaked onto the sheets below.

Katsuki's tongue worked in tandem, withdrawing to lick stripes up from Izuku's balls up to the rim, sucking gently on the sack to draw out a fresh wave of pre-cum from Izuku's tip.

Izuku's groans turned frantic as he was devoured. His hands fisted the pillows so tightly the fabric nearly tore under his grip. He arched impossibly higher, knees sliding wider apart on the bed, offering every inch of himself to Katsuki.

"K-Kacchan—right there," he begged, voice wrecked and dripping with desperation.

His body rocked back to meet each thrust, hole sucking greedily around the intrusion as tears of overwhelming ecstasy pricked at his eyes.

The air thickened with the scent of their arousal as Katsuki's own cock ached painfully in his pants. But he poured every ounce of his passion into unraveling Izuku, determined to push him to the edge with this intimate worship. His tongue kept going, delving deep alongside his fingers pounding that delicious spot until Izuku was a trembling, sobbing mess of bliss.

His gaze shifted to the nightstand, where the lotion bottle gleamed faintly in the low light. He pulled away with a slick sound, smirking at Izuku's protesting throaty sob.

He sat back on his heels, eyes raking over Izuku's flushed body. He drank it all in: the motion in which his legs trembled. And then the way his head was turned to the side on the pillow, eyes looking over his shoulder at him.

"If I could fuck you right now, I'd do it," Katsuki groaned. He began rubbing himself through his pants, drinking in the sight of Izuku's sloppy hole. "God. I'd give it to you *so* fucking good you wouldn't be able to think straight for a week."

"You can use my legs," Izuku suggested, eyes dilating until there was only black.

"Yeah?" Katsuki bit his lip and gripped his cock harder. "You want me to fuck these pretty thighs of yours?"

Izuku nodded and shifted his hips more.

Katsuki exhaled eagerly, nose flaring. He scrambled for the nightstand, reaching for the lotion bottle on the other side of the lamp. He clicked the cap open and poured a thick stream into his hand. The gentle scent of vanilla filled the air as he rubbed his palms together to warm the cream.

"Lower your hips," Katsuki whispered.

Izuku nodded and slowly pressed himself flat to the mattress in anticipation.

All Katsuki could think was how damn *lucky* he was.

He started with Izuku's back, spreading lotion over the soft skin and kneading deep into the tense muscles. Izuku relaxed into his touch, eyes blinking slowly closed as Katsuki worked his coarse hands across his body.

Gradually, he moved down, taking his time to ground Izuku into the touch. Katsuki wanted his darling to know he was safe, and that he'd always take good care of all his needs. He moved lower, thumbs dipping into the cleft of Izuku's backside, coating the sensitive skin around that puckered entrance, making Izuku whimper and push back.

Katsuki's hands slid farther, slathering the lotion along Izuku's inner thighs. His fingers brushed teasingly close to Izuku's sensitive balls, making the other man moan and twitch. He grinned mischievously as he went up again, sinking his firm fingers into Izuku's muscular globes.

He continued like that, working the slickness everywhere across Izuku's skin and ensuring every inch was slippery, primed for what was coming next.

Gripping his own throbbing erection, Katsuki swiftly pulled down his pajama pants. His heavy cock hung free and was smeared with pre-cum. He grabbed the base and aligned it with the valley between Izuku's plush backside. He thrust forward, sliding his length along the lotion smeared skin.

They both groaned as the thick head of his cock caught on Izuku's rim with each pass. The smaller man jolted as the thick tip nudged his hole, not entering but pressing just enough to

tease.

“Kacchan,” Izuku hissed. He pushed back on it, biting his lip. “That feels good. K-Keep going.”

Katsuki grunted, hips rocking steadily. The friction built until it became hot and maddening. Obeying Izuku’s orders, he did it again and again. Pre-cum smeared Izuku’s entrance as his tip bumped and dragged over the tiny hole.

His fiancé’s breaths came out in steady, ragged pants. His hands clawed at the pillows as he whined, hips wiggling to chase more contact.

“Put it in, just a little,” Izuku begged. “It’s driving me insane.”

Katsuki’s lips curled into a smirk as he gripped the base of his thick cock. He pressed the fat tip right up against Izuku’s wet hole, feeling the tight ring clench instinctively around nothing, begging to be filled.

“Only a bit,” Katsuki whispered, voice laced with hunger. “Don’t wanna hurt you.”

He didn’t give Izuku time to beg more. Instead, he pushed forward just enough to breach the rim. The broad tip popped past the resistance with a lewd, wet squelch that made both of them hiss in ecstasy. Izuku’s legs jolted like he’d been shocked, and his mouth fell open with a small gasp.

Katsuki could’ve rolled his eyes back in his head. That initial stretch burned so damn good. The exquisite vice of Izuku’s hole clamping down on his tip sent shocks of rapture straight to his core. Every involuntary flutter Izuku gave, pulled him in deeper without even meaning to.

“K-Kacchan…” Izuku breathed, pushing back ever so slightly.

Katsuki pulled back deliberately, letting the head drag out with a slick pop that echoed in the dark room. His fiancé’s hips bucked up involuntarily, chasing that fullness he’d only just tasted.

“*More*,” Izuku insisted, pushing back.

“Not yet,” Katsuki hissed.

He smacked one hand down on Izuku’s thigh to still him. The sharp sting made Izuku’s cock jump and leak more pre-cum onto the sheets.

Katsuki lined up again, pressing the tip flush against that pretty damn hole, and thrusted shallowly. He pushed his tip in, stretching the tight muscle around his girth before he withdrew.

He did it again, and again. Each time feeling better than the last. Every wet pop was an obscene, filthy sound that had Katsuki’s balls tightening. His own breath hitched as he watched Izuku’s ass cling to him, reluctant to let go.

His darling's response was a broken moan. His body was trembling uncontrollable as Katsuki repeated the motion, fucking him with only the tip in short, torturous dips. Each shallow thrust popped the head in and out. The rim stretched and snapped back with every vulgar slide, building a maddening friction that had Izuku's toes curling and his thighs quaking around Katsuki's body.

"C'mon, Kacchan. Fuck me deeper," Izuku begged.

Satisfied with the desperation in Izuku's ragged pants, Katsuki shifted lower. He guided his cock between those slick, muscular thighs and swallowed the throaty groan that pushed out of his throat. Izuku clamped his thighs together instinctively, creating a tight channel that hugged Katsuki's girthy shaft perfectly.

"That's it. Squeeze me tight," Katsuki ordered.

He snapped his hips to slide in deep, and they both moaned at the sensation. His cock glided smoothly through the slick lotion, the tip grinding against Izuku's hard length. He tested a movement, and he could feel his length rubbing his fiancé's hard-on in tandem with the wet drag.

He set a deep pace that made them both close their eyes in pleasure. As he fucked those plush thighs, Katsuki leaned over Izuku's back. His chest pressed down on the smaller man, caging him in as he began grinding against the curve of Izuku's ass. The motion pressed Izuku's cock into the soft mattress, trapping it there with relentless pressure.

Katsuki intensified his movements, sliding in and out with greater force while nuzzling his face into the warm crook of Izuku's neck.

His hands swiftly overtook Izuku's. He interlaced their fingers before guiding one of Izuku's palms downward. He directed it to the throbbing length of Izuku's neglected cock, compelling him to stroke himself amid their fervent rutting. Izuku's loud moan echoed as Katsuki's larger hand assisted in the firm pumps that heightened their mutual pleasure.

Izuku's cute keens heightened as Katsuki's pace built. He began rutting quicker, and the wet sounds of their skin slapping echoed in the room. His balls hit against Izuku's with each drive. The way he humped forward made his shaft grind deeper into the thighs' vice.

Izuku's moans transformed into high-pitched cries as he ground back against Katsuki. He began vigorously pumping his cock and bit his lip. The lewd feeling of Katsuki's thick length battering against his sensitive area from behind sent waves of heat down his back every time.

Izuku's voice broke in a desperate sob. "Ah—Kacchan, it's so fucking good."

His thighs trembled violently around Katsuki's hot cock, squeezing it in rhythmic spasms that milked every inch. In the heat of the moment, Katsuki's fingers dug into Izuku's hands with bruising force, pinning them down as he hammered forward. He chased the explosive release building in his core.

"Cum with me, darling," he growled, his breath hot against Izuku's ear.

The tension coiled tighter in their cores, a brutal wave ready to destroy them both. Katsuki's hips snapped erratically. His cock moved wildly as he drove through the slick, sweat-slicked gap between Izuku's thighs one last punishing time.

With a guttural groan, he erupted.

He unleashed thick ropes of hot cum that splattered across Izuku's freckled skin, painting the plush flesh in sticky white streaks. His body locked up, muscles seizing as the orgasm ripped through him. He gave several pathetic, grinding thrusts deeper into the vise of those quivering legs, claiming his future husband with feral intensity.

The scorching flood of cum washed against Izuku's cock, mingling with the slick mess between them. Coupled with Katsuki's harsh pants directly into his ear, it hurled Izuku over the edge in a graceless rush.

He shattered with a piercing wail, cock pulsing heavy spurts of semen. The thick liquid smeared across their joined, clenched hands in messy bursts. But Katsuki didn't relent. His grip tightened to deliver sharp, overstimulating strokes that dragged out Izuku's climax. Izuku shuddered helplessly as Katsuki's mouth latched onto the sweat-damp skin of his neck and sucked hard.

The smaller man bucked and convulsed beneath him, lost in the overwhelming euphoria. Katsuki kept going, playing with Izuku's sensitive length, thumb sliding across the spent tip. He kept going, fondling and playing with Izuku until he was a sobbing mess that collapsed fully onto the sheets.

When he was satisfied with Izuku's whine, Katsuki decided he was spent. He slumped his full weight onto the smaller man with his softening cock still wedged snugly between those shuddering thighs. His arms banded around Izuku's waist in a possessive hold as they gasped for air in sync.

They came down in unison through the afterglow, slick with sweat. Their bodies entwined in perfect, sated harmony.

Katsuki nuzzled a soft kiss at Izuku's temple, murmuring hoarsely, "I love you."

Izuku melted with a blissful sigh. He twisted to claim Katsuki's lips in a slow, deep kiss that lingered with lazy heat.

"And I love you too, Kacchan. Always."

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki practically walked with a damn skip in his step on the way back to the hospital room. He hummed under his breath too. It was a barely there tune that matched how damn freakin' he was. In his hand, a small bouquet of yellow flowers bobbed as he strolled down the hall.

Everything was finally falling into place. That bastard Tomura was gone. The crazy Chisakis were basically wiped off the map. And the other Yakuza were too busy stumbling over their

own corpses to catch their breath, let alone catch them.

But better than all that, his Izuku was awake.

He grinned to himself, absolutely unashamed. Maybe he should make today a holiday: the day the stars finally lined up for once.

When Katsuki walked through the door to Izuku's private room, his fiancé smiled at him instantly. Izuku's infectious grin spread to him and his stomach filled with butterflies.

As he approached, Izuku's legs swung idly over the side of the bed. It was a small, absentminded habit Katsuki missed like hell. Besides Izuku, Miruko glanced over her shoulder while injecting another round of medication into Izuku's arm.

She caught his ridiculous upbeat stride, snorted, and shook her head.

"Welcome back," she said with humor. "Another round of flowers, huh?"

Katsuki flashed her a crooked grin and lifted the bouquet. "Yup. I figured I'd bring him my own medicine too. I heard flowers are supposed to make people heal faster or whatever."

"That's not true in the slightest," Miruko huffed, rolling her eyes.

Izuku laughed, voice still a little raspy. "Maybe not for everyone. But I feel better already just looking at them."

Katsuki grinned wide and happily plopped down onto the bed next to his future husband. "Knew you would like them."

Izuku leaned into him just slightly, and their shoulders brushed.

Miruko chuckled under her breath as she switched out the medication. She checked his vitals, asked him to stand, and to take a deep breath in and out. Izuku obeyed and did the tasks with ease despite meeting a small amount of resistance. Miruko gave a tiny, satisfied hum.

"Congratulations," she said brightly as she put a smiley face bandaid on his arm. "You're officially on a small but steady upward climb. You'll be safe to travel by tomorrow!"

"Hell yes," Katsuki cheered with a lopsided smirk. "Knew he'd bounce back fast."

Izuku laughed softly too, gratitude glowing in his eyes. Unable to help himself, Katsuki ran a hand through Izuku's messy curls and ruffled them up.

"He's one hell of a fighter," Miruko complimented, gathering her supplies. "I've got a few other patients to check on, but I'll see you both downstairs soon."

"Yup," Katsuki replied, popping the last syllable just to be a little obnoxious. "We'll be down there."

"See you soon, Miruko!" Izuku called after her as she made for the door.

“Don’t get into trouble,” she shot back with a wave before disappearing into the hall.

When it was only the two of them, Katsuki took a moment to listen to the room. The soft hum of machines filled the silence, along with the drone of the news in the background.

“Thank you for the flowers,” Izuku said, full of affection. “They’re the same ones you got me when we stayed at Midnight’s. Was that on purpose?”

“It was,” Katsuki admitted. “When I went to the flower shop, I saw them and thought of you.”

Izuku’s smile spread. He leaned in, and together they shared a grateful kiss. When they broke apart, Katsuki knew the smile on his face probably looked damn near stupid.

He rose to his feet and wandered over to the other bouquets crowding the table and windowsill. Each one sat in their own individual vase. He raised a brow as he sifted through the mess of bouquets, trying to find room for the new one.

“We’re gonna need a bigger damn room,” he muttered.

Thank fuck Izuku had woken up after two weeks. Because if the coma had gone longer, he’d have to stack bouquets on the damn floor. Katsuki shifted a few vases aside, grumbling the whole time. He then moved a small book off the sill to make room for the newest arrangement. Without thinking, he set the little book down on the mattress beside Izuku.

Izuku’s head tilted curiously. His gaze went to it, and a small, startled sound slipped from him.

“How did this get here?” he asked, voice high with surprise.

Katsuki hummed distractedly as he adjusted the flowers. He half turned to glance over his shoulder, and he saw Izuku holding the paperback book in both his hands. The title ‘Saishū kōkyōkyoku’ stared back at him in all its curvy, exaggerated lavender font.

“Oh, that?” Katsuki said casually. “I went out and found another copy of your nerdy romance book. I was reading it out loud to you while you were under.”

Izuku glanced up. “You were?”

“Yeah.” Katsuki shrugged, rubbing the back of his neck. “Miruko said talking helps coma patients, so I figured, why not read you your favorite book? Maybe you’d wake up if you heard some of your favorite passages.”

“Did I respond at all?”

“Not really. But I *swore* I got a twitch out of you during that perverted fireplace scene you like so much.”

Katsuki flashed a toothy grin and Izuku blushed.

“I finished the whole thing, by the way,” Katsuki continued as he fussed with the flowers. “It was actually good. I should’ve taken you more seriously when you told me to read it.”

Pleased with the bouquet’s positioning, he moved away and looked at Izuku.

But when he did, he found his fiancé staring at him with that look. That incredibly cute, admiration-filled stare that never failed to make Katsuki’s heart twist around and around. Izuku held the book against his chest like he used to with a smile so tender it could’ve melted stone.

“What?” Katsuki frowned, a little defensive from embarrassment. “Why’re you lookin’ at me like that with those big ass eyes?”

“Nothing.” Izuku laughed, full of fondness. “I just can’t believe you ever thought you couldn’t be soft. You’re the biggest softie in the world.”

Katsuki’s grin returned, crooked and bashful. He scratched his cheek, trying to disguise the validation rising in his chest.

“Just for you,” he teased. “Don’t go tellin’ everyone. I’ve got a reputation to uphold. I’m supposed to be a big scary serial killer or whatever.”

Izuku snorted, chuckling from deep in his chest.

“Oh, that reputation is gone, Kacchan,” Izuku said through his smile. “*Long* gone.”

He reached out for Katsuki’s hand. With his thumb, he felt out the bumps on his future husband’s knuckles, cataloging the injuries. Katsuki held his hand back, and Izuku laced their fingers together.

“Does this mean we can talk about it together now?” Izuku asked a little too eagerly. “I’ve always wanted someone to discuss it with.”

“Well *duh*, nerd,” Katsuki laughed. “I’m going to need to read the sequel and the prequel now too. Because what the hell was up with the part where you learn about the mountain village? We never get to see them again. It felt like such a tease.”

Izuku snickered again, and it warmed Katsuki’s whole body.

He took a moment to sit in that sound and listen to how wonderful it was. He privately swore to keep Izuku laughing like that forever, for the rest of their lives.

☽ ☽ ☾ ☾

Izuku smiled so much that he could feel it in his cheeks.

The whole day so far was good. Peaceful, even. It was his first full day conscious since the coma, and he’d spent most of it rebuilding his strength and trying to look ahead.

He did various exercises and walked the hallways up and down with Katsuki at his side. They both laughed through the clumsy stretches that Katsuki jokingly called ‘Izuku baby steps.’ His future husband helped the whole time, offering boisterous encouragement or teasing remarks to keep the mood light.

By dinner, Izuku felt like he had regained a bit more of his mobility. He still leaned on Katsuki for balance, but not as much as before.

When they sat down to eat, the mood was lighter than the previous day. It was apparent everyone’s spirits had lifted now that Izuku was awake. The pseudo cafeteria was crowded with laughter and the faint churn of chaotic conversation.

Across from him, Sero had made a game out of flicking peas at Denki until Aizawa sighed and told them to grow up. Monoma and Shinsou were quietly gossiping, no doubt. They were discreetly pointing at some of the other agents in the large room.

And at his side was his Katsuki. His shoulder was pressed against his and every now and then he muttered sarcastic remarks that made Izuku snicker into his plate.

Everything felt nice—like it had before.

Aizawa turned toward Izuku with a tired smile. “How are you feeling?”

“Good.” Izuku rolled his shoulders and offered a small nod. “Better than I thought I’d be. Surprisingly, I’m not feeling so terrible.”

“That’s great to hear,” Aizawa said, his tone light with relief. “Honestly, I expected you to need a few more days, given how far along the poisoning was.”

“That’s because he’s tough as hell,” Katsuki interjected proudly. “Strongest damn nerd I know.”

Izuku let out a quiet laugh. Even Aizawa couldn’t help but chuckle, shaking his head.

“Do you think you’ll be well enough to travel soon then?” Aizawa asked. “I don’t mean to rush, but the sooner we reach Nana, the better. The Yakuza families are still in disarray, but that won’t last. Waiting too long will allow Chisaki loyalists to find us again.”

Izuku nodded, resolute. “Tomorrow should be fine. You’re right. The sooner we move, the better.”

“Alright,” Aizawa said softly. “Tomorrow it is.”

At the thought of Nana, Izuku grinned without intending to.

But his happiness carried a turbulent anxiety behind his ribs. Mainly because of what happened last time. Even though he knew there was no Tomura or Chisaki Kai to hunt them down—he still couldn’t help but feel uneasy. Or maybe he was still in disbelief that they could truly reach safety.

In the middle of all the table's ongoing conversation, he turned to the window.

Outside, the city of Yokohama stretched out underneath a setting sun. For the first time in weeks, the snow had finally stopped pouring down. There were more people outside, enjoying the minor break in the winter weather.

"Oh man, it looks great out," Katsuki said beside him.

"Yeah, it's nice," Izuku agreed. "Its lovely to see a change in weather."

At the end of their meal, everyone moved to clean up. All of them stacked their plates and began walking towards the exit of the cafeteria area. As soon as they reached the mouth of the door, Izuku felt a gentle tap on his shoulder.

He turned, and there Aizawa stood behind him. His eyes were their usual tired, but there was also an added layer of apprehension.

"I got the cremator in the basement up and running," he said quietly. "We can do it today or tomorrow."

Izuku froze. Next to him, Katsuki went still too.

All humor drained from both of their faces as the mood shifted. It took a moment for Izuku to process what was about to happen.

"It's up to you," Aizawa tacked on when he didn't answer right away. "There's no real rush if you don't want to do it. I can also do it for you."

Izuku shook his head and pulled himself into focus.

"We can do it today," he whispered. "I don't want to hold us up."

Katsuki reached over without a word. He took his hand and squeezed it once.

ᔓᔓᔓ

The basement of The Company was quiet as a funeral would've been. Izuku liked to think that was good.

All around were clean, white walls that were as cold and colorless as his brother used to be. The faint scent of oil and ash hung in the air. The floor was a pristine white tile, and the ceiling was absent of any cobwebs.

For a place built to burn the dead, it was tidy, much to Izuku's surprise.

Him, Aizawa, and Katsuki all stood near an old cremator. It was made of silver metal, and big enough to fit a body. Izuku studied the large pipes and the gaping opening as Aizawa prepared the controls. His future husband lingered close by with his hands shoved deep in his pockets.

In front of them, Tomura laid out underneath a pale linen sheet. Izuku neatly folded the edges, taking gentle care to be as respectful as possible. He thought maybe being orderly could make up for everything that had gone wrong between them.

He reached out, brushing a hand over the fabric before pulling it back to reveal his brother's face one last time. He took a gracious moment of silence. The sharp edges of Tomura's features were softened, and his mouth was no longer twisted by exhaustion or fury.

That never-ending grief returned to Izuku's chest.

"He looks so tranquil," Izuku whispered as he smoothed Tomura's hair back. "I don't think I've ever seen him like this."

"The last thing he saw was you," Katsuki said. "That's probably why."

And that broke his heart. Izuku blinked back tears, and his throat tightened at the image of Tomura glancing at him one last time as he went. With a deep breath, he fortified his heart. He turned to his fiancé and nodded, ready.

Together they lifted Tomura.

It took both of them and all the strength he had. His brother's weight was the sum of a lifetime spent surviving, and Izuku felt every ounce of it in his arms. As they loaded him inside, he wished his throat unlocked. But it stayed clamped tight, reminding him how much he loved his brother despite all the pain he caused.

When Tomura was fully seated inside, Izuku took a step back. He closed the incinerator's door, and the finality of it all cut deeper than he'd expected. This was the last time he'd ever see him.

Katsuki rested his hands on Izuku's shoulders.

"You can start it whenever you're ready," he said softly. "No rush."

Aizawa stood at a respectful distance, saying nothing. Now, the air felt too still. The world too patient. It was as if time itself finally decided to wait, and allow Izuku to choose when to let go.

He stepped forward.

His fingers hovered above the ignition lever, trembling. On his shoulders, Katsuki's thumbs brushed affectionate circles into his skin, coaxing him to breathe. Izuku exhaled shakily and then drew in one last breath.

He screwed his eyes shut and pulled the lever down.

The furnace roared to life. All around, the air in the room filled with the growl of fire devouring what was inside. Bright solemn flames gradually built into a beautiful blaze, spilling gold and red across the white walls.

Izuku flinched at the crackle at first. Then he relaxed and looked headfirst into the funeral pyre. It was strange. It differed from any fire he'd ever seen. Somehow, it moved with quiet sorrow. Its glow was soft and thoughtful, consuming not in violence but in grace. Almost as if it understood the value of what it was taking.

Katsuki stayed beside him throughout the entire process. He didn't speak. Didn't move. His fiancé simply stood close enough for him to lean against.

When Izuku crumbled under grief, Katsuki's arms wrapped around him and held him up.

ᗰᗰᗰ

It took several hours. The whole time, they stayed in the room.

As the hours passed, Izuku traced the years backwards. He reflected on every cruel word and every fleeting moment of tenderness. He mourned quietly for who Tomura might've been if life had been kinder. Maybe then his brother would have chosen another path other than absolute power.

By the time it was over, it was well into the night. The fire sent Tomura off in enchanting embers, and the weight in Izuku's chest felt lighter.

When the ashes cooled down, Aizawa opened the chamber and carefully swept the remains onto a metal tray. Izuku wiped his tears with the back of his hand and stepped forward. He began to help with the transfer. As he looked at the grey ashes, he experienced an emotion that was part sorrow and part relief.

Katsuki turned and went to retrieve one of the urns The Company had in storage. It was dark grey and had a silver lining. He handed it silently to Izuku, and Izuku did his best to ensure his hands didn't shake too much as he handled it.

Together, they transferred the ashes. When the last remnants slid inside, Izuku placed the lid on top and sealed it tightly.

With tender care, he held the urn close against his chest. It was shockingly light. Almost too light for who was inside, but the thought made him smile faintly. Maybe that was how it should be. Tomura was finally unburdened after a lifetime of struggling to the top.

"Rest well," Izuku whispered.

☽ ☽ᗰ☾ ☾

As they made their way up to their room, Katsuki's eyes lingered on Izuku the whole way.

The smaller man held the urn tight to his chest, cradling it protectively. The solemn look in Izuku's eyes softened Katsuki's resentment of Tomura a bit. But only a bit. For all the hatred he held towards that abusive piece of shit, he was glad Izuku had been granted a proper goodbye.

It wasn't perfect, but it was something.

When they reached their room, Katsuki blinked in mild surprise to find Miruko waiting for them. She was lounging on the couch with her legs crossed and filing her nails casually. At her feet sat two ridiculously large black suitcases and two duffel bags.

"What's all this?" Katsuki asked, drawing her attention.

She turned, and perked up instantly at the sight of them.

"Hey there," she greeted with a grin. She stood, grabbed the bags and dragged them closer. "I come bearing gifts. One for you, and one for you." She nudged one suitcase toward Izuku, the other toward Katsuki. "Inside are all the essentials for your trip. Pretty much any clothes you'll need, snacks, and toiletries."

Izuku's expression softened, a genuine smile curving his lips as he set Tomura's urn gently on the table beside the flowers.

"Thank you," he said warmly. "You didn't have to do that."

"Yeah, seriously," Katsuki added. "This is kinda unlike you."

Miruko shrugged. "It was Aizawa's doing. He's been fussing for weeks about what you two might need once you're on the road." She shot them both a teasing grin. "If there's anything missing, let the old man know. He'll pretend to be annoyed but gladly get on with it right away."

Katsuki's brows rose, touched despite himself. "Uh, yeah…will do."

"Good. Then I'll leave you two to it. If you need anything, I'll be in the west corridor. I'm staying late to catch up on paperwork."

And with that, she gave a playful wave and slipped out the door.

At the same time, both Izuku and Katsuki handled the suitcases. They put them on their backs to zip them open to inspect what was inside. As he stared at the various items, Katsuki didn't quite know what to think. But he was thankful. Quietly, he held up one of the spicy snacks he always gravitated towards. As he inspected the plastic wrapping, he realized Aizawa knew him well. He had always known that, but this time it made his heart warm stupidly.

"You're very lucky to have Aizawa," Izuku said as he shuffled through some of his new shirts. He smiled gently.

"Yeah," Katsuki agreed. "I got, uh, really lucky with him."

As they sifted through the bags Katsuki noted a couple of things.

First, each one was full of fresh clothes. Everything was similar to the style he always wore. Black on black, simple and functional. But there was also a hint of orange that surprised him. He'd been leaning towards that color only after Izuku came into his life.

Aizawa saw him in orange once: during his retirement party.

It had been such a small moment, a fleeting blip he assumed no one but Izuku took seriously.

But Aizawa had.

The last thing he noticed was Izuku's eyes flicking over to Tomura's urn. It didn't take a genius to see how fast the damn nerd's brain was turning. His fiancé no doubt was stuck in an uphill battle, wrestling with the concept of his brother being gone.

A truth like that would take long to swallow. Katsuki knew first hand. Because even though he loved his mother, probably as much as Izuku loved his brother, they both had to accept that they were better off without them. Izuku would get there, he was positive.

But it was still a really, damn sad sight to watch.

Izuku's gaze lingered too long on the urn for Katsuki's liking. He watched as Izuku's fingers twitched faintly, and the pull of grief worked its way back into Izuku's face.

He hated seeing Izuku sit in that type of silence. Like, *really* fucking hated it.

So he cleared his throat and broke it. "Wanna go out on the town for a bit?"

Izuku turned to him, startled. "What? Kacchan—no. That is a little too dangerous."

"It'll be fine." Katsuki huffed and waved a dismissive hand. "Those Yakuza bastards are too busy. You think they've got time to look for us right now? They've got what, three hundred funerals to plan?"

Izuku tried not to laugh, but failed. But even through the humor he fidgeted with his hands, twisting his fingers together.

"…Where would we even go?" he asked quietly, uncertainty weaving across his words.

Katsuki gave a small snort, half offended. "We're in *my* city, nerd. I've lived here half my whole life. You think I don't know a few places worth seeing? Besides—" he tilted his head, eyes softening by a fraction, "—you could use some air."

Izuku hesitated. His eyes darted between Katsuki, the window, and the urn. He bit his lip, big ass brain weighing his options. Then slowly, a small smile painted across his face.

"Okay," Izuku said at last. "Let's do it."

Katsuki grinned wider. "That's my darling."

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki tucked the fluffy scarf around Izuku's neck one last time, pulling it snug so the smaller man huddled into its warmth. They shared a short, private smile as a pair of night-shift agents drifted past them in the lobby.

“I’ll be right back,” Katsuki said. “I’m gonna ask Miruko for something.”

“Okay, I’ll try not to run away,” Izuku teased with bright eyes.

Katsuki zipped his leather jacket up and took off down the hallway. As he walked, he shuffled through the list of places he wanted to show Izuku before they left. In an odd way, he was going to enjoy chauffeuring his dork around Yokohama. It’d been the place he’d called home ever since Aizawa took him under his wing. He had a decent number of good memories here.

When he reached Miruko’s office, her door was cracked open. Through the gap he could see her leaning over her laptop with her glasses perched on the tip of her nose.

He tapped on the door in a rhythmic cadence and pushed it fully open. Miruko turned and groaned when she saw him.

“Shouldn’t you be resting?” She chastised.

With the biggest shit eating grin he could manage, Katsuki asked, “Can I borrow the keys to your bike?”

Like expected, her face dropped, entirely unimpressed.

“And *where* exactly do you think you’re going, Casanova?” she asked, staring him down over the rim of her glasses. “Trying to impress your little husband?”

“And if I am?” Katsuki replied, rubbing his nose to hide the rising warmth in his cheeks. “I’m just gonna take Izuku for a quick spin, nothing wild. He needs some fresh air before we’re boxed in a ship for god knows how long.”

Miruko clicked her tongue, disapproving. But then a slow, infectious grin spread across her face.

“Fine,” she laughed with a sharp snort. “But only because I like Izuku so much. If he weren’t part of the equation, I wouldn’t let you touch my bike ever again. Not after you fucking stole it when you were a teen.”

“I didn’t steal it,” Katsuki barked. “I was borrowing it.”

“Whatever you’re telling yourself these days.” She dug into the drawer beside her desk and produced a ring of keys. She held them up and narrowed her eyes. “If you put one scratch on that bike like last time, I’ll track you down and make you pay. I don’t care where that mystery lady hides you, I will find you.”

Katsuki rolled his eyes and caught the keys when she tossed them.

“Yeah, yeah. I know—you’ll find me and skin me alive,” he mocked lazily. “Thanks, Miruko.”

“Tell Izuku to enjoy the night for me!”

☽ ☽ ☽

Izuku stared in awe at the sleek white motorcycle.

Its iridescent chrome glowed like moonlight, and the lavender decals sat beautifully against its pristine frame. He circled it once, fingertips brushing the handlebars as though afraid to taint it with his fingerprints.

“And Miruko’s actually okay with us using her bike?” Izuku asked, fully incredulous as Katsuki handed him motorcycle goggles. “This thing is gorgeous. I don’t think I’d let anyone touch it if it were mine.”

“Yeah, she’s super chill about it,” Katsuki replied with a cocky grin. He arrogantly pointed his thumb at his chest. “I was basically her favorite agent in M-Unit. She lets me borrow it all the time.”

Izuku gave a slow, skeptical smile. “For some reason, I find that oddly hard to believe, Kacchan.”

“Well, believe it, dork,” Katsuki shot back, putting on the helmet. “She trusts me more than half the idiots employed at our agency. Now quit talkin’ and get on before I change my mind.”

Izuku chuckled as he pulled the goggles over his eyes.

“Yes, sir,” he teased.

Katsuki hopped on and inserted the key. His chest swarmed with those damn butterflies again when Izuku settled in behind him. The leather seat was cool and slick beneath them, and the faint smell of gasoline clung to the air as Katsuki turned the key. With a throaty growl, the engine roared to life. The headlight blared, carving a clean beam through the dimly lit garage.

“Ready?” Katsuki asked over his shoulder.

Izuku’s arms slid around his waist, snug and steady. “Always.”

They sped out of the garage, and the echo of the engine got swallowed by the vast night. Once they emerged from the outside, all around them the city of Yokohama stretched. Buildings and people passed by them in colorful streaks of light. Through the helmet, Katsuki could hear the radio on the dashboard.

Right as he hit the long stretch of highway, the first raindrops fell.

It was barely there at first. But then it happened again, like the world was finally done holding its breath.

Izuku’s voice came muffled against the collar of Katsuki’s jacket. “Are you sure this was a good idea?”

Katsuki smirked without looking back. “What, you’re scared of a little rain?”

“I’m scared of you getting a dent in Miruko’s bike,” Izuku shot back, his words barely audible over the rising wind. “I would like to get to Nana in one piece!”

Katsuki laughed. Like truly, really laughed. It was loud, wild, and *alive* for the first time in months.

“Relax. I know every turn in this city. I could drive it blindfolded.”

“Please don’t test that,” Izuku said, but there was laughter in his voice too.

The drizzle thickened, and the rain became a soft curtain that blurred the edges of the streetlights. The droplets caught in the headlight like scattered diamonds and made the music vibrate underneath his fingertips. Around him, his city’s pulse became covered in liquid. The familiar skyscrapers glowed through the mist, and puddles reflected every color in the world.

Izuku’s laughter rose when Katsuki made a sharp turn. The world blurred further into streaks of color and rain sliced across the night. The wetness hit their legs, their hands, and their jackets. But neither of them suggested turning back.

He should’ve been annoyed, but instead he felt rejuvenated and refreshed—and it only pushed him harder.

The music on the radio switched, and Katsuki felt a small wave of fission ignite along his arms.

Behind him, Izuku’s grip tightened when they hit a winding road. His fiancé let out a small yelp as they twisted and turned unpredictably. It was exhilarating. With a wild surge, Katsuki hit the gas harder. Izuku squeezed him tightly then and tilted his head back, letting the rain soak him.

“God, I forgot what this felt like,” Izuku shouted over the roar.

“What, being alive?” Katsuki called back.

“Yeah,” Izuku said, and Katsuki could hear the smile in it. “Exactly that.”

That’s what Katsuki wanted to hear. With a daring glance in the mirror, he caught sight of Izuku’s reflection.

And it was beautiful.

Izuku’s head was tilted to the sky and his mouth was pulled into a light smile. His curls were blowing in the subtle drizzle. He looked like he was breathing for the first time in years.

Out of sheer joy, Katsuki let out a loud laugh and twisted the throttle.

The bike surged forward, roaring down the slick road. Water sprayed up from the tires, shining like silver dust in their wake. The cold wind slapped their skin, but it didn’t bite. It merely woke them up further.

“Hold on tight!” Katsuki yelled.

“I already am!” Izuku’s voice was bright and fearless. “You’re insane, Kacchan!”

“Damn right I am!” Katsuki shouted back, grinning like a maniac.

They sped through the dark until a tunnel appeared. It was large, and full of a yellow glow that waited for them with open arms. No one else was in sight, and the opening was entirely empty—so Katsuki didn’t slow down. He throttled harder, plunging them inside at an intoxicating speed.

The world exploded into a dazzling yellow.

Each bulb overhead zoomed past like a miniature sun, melting into the next until the tunnel became a corridor of liquid gold. Izuku’s laughter rose and scattered into the night. The sound was brilliant, catching like starlight in Katsuki’s chest.

He turned up the volume on the radio, threw his head back and let out a loud yell that mixed with his chaotic laughter. The echo came back like thunder, and Izuku’s laughter fused with it, fully unrestrained.

“Kacchan!” Izuku shouted, voice cracking with joy. “What are you doing?!”

“Letting it out!” Katsuki hollered. “Try it! Scream a little, I know you want to!”

Izuku tried.

He began hesitantly, but then slowly his yells snowballed, each one building on the other. Then finally, it all belted out of him in a final howl. He poured out all the frustration that had made a home in his chest.

Together, they yelled. Their voices bounced off the walls, blending with the revving of the bike and music.

In that tunnel, for a moment, they weren’t killers. They were somehow simply kids again. Kids who were reckless enough to believe they were invincible in a world that always reminded them they weren’t.

When they burst out the other end of the tunnel, the rain had softened to a floating mist.

The city lights glowed ahead of them, reflecting off the standing pools of water scattered across the road. Their laughter tapered off, and what was left made a weight inside of Katsuki shift. It was odd. Like a stone he wasn’t aware of inside his chest had been demolished.

When they were riding in comfortable silence, Izuku leaned forward. He rested his cheek against Katsuki’s back, and his arms wrapped tighter.

“You were right,” Izuku said softly. “This was a good idea.”

“Of course it was,” Katsuki replied. “You deserve to feel good.”

They rode on, entirely quiet now. The sound of the rain filled the space between them where words couldn't. The road stretched endlessly. And for the first time since everything had fallen apart, they weren't running from the past. They were racing toward a future—one bright enough to believe in.

☽ ☽ ☽

The rain thinned to a silver mist by the time they reached the city's center.

Yokohama's night scene sang with bustling crowds and bright billboards holding celebrity faces. Katsuki guided the bike through the maze of traffic as he weaved in and out of the streets he knew by heart.

Originally, he didn't plan on talking. He only wanted to show his nerd a couple of his favorite spots. Just to, like, see the guy smile. Nothing big. But there was a specific magic about the city at night that always pulled to him. Driving by the familiar corners made words slip out before he could stop them.

"See that building up ahead?" Katsuki called over his shoulder. "The one with the ugly ass green sign? That used to be my high school after we moved here."

"Really?" Izuku said, head tilting slightly to look. "You actually went there?"

"Yeah. I hated every second. Not too many of my classmates liked me. Although, it wasn't like I was exactly fond of their dumbasses either. Those extras always said I had anger issues." He paused. A humorless laugh caught in his throat. "Guess they weren't exactly wrong about that part."

They weaved down another set of narrow streets and under low overpasses. When the city opened up again, he slowed near a corner bistro.

"That place," Katsuki said, nodding toward it, "has the best karaage in the whole damn city. I used to come here after some assignments. The owner used to sneak me a beer even when I was underage. I had helped him handle some knuckleheads that were giving him a hard time."

Izuku laughed. "Sounds like you've always had a thing for helping others."

"Duh." Katsuki smirked, but it didn't reach his eyes. "It's the right thing to do."

He didn't realize how quiet he'd gone until Izuku spoke again. His fiancé's tone was thoughtful.

"You talk about this place like it was another lifetime."

"Yeah," Katsuki muttered. "Feels like it, huh?"

They took a turn onto a residential street. Over here, the buildings were close together like tired old friends. Katsuki slowed the bike and nodded towards one of the apartment complexes.

“That one on the top floor, that’s where my apartment is—or, I guess, was.”

Izuku’s chin rested lightly on his shoulder now, and Katsuki could feel his gaze travel up.

“It looks nice,” Izuku said. “How long did you live there?”

“Since I was seventeen,” Katsuki replied. “Moved in right after I left my mom’s place—if you remember.” He exhaled unhappily. That memory was always a shitty one to recall. “That was right after I found out about my connection to Imasuji Goto.”

Silence hung between them for a moment. It was thick over the hum of the idling engine.

It hit him then: this was probably the last time he’d ever see this building. Or this street as a matter of fact. But why did that make him feel sad? Ultimately, it shouldn’t matter. It was just a dumb apartment and a dumb road. He had bigger problems like making sure the Yakuza didn’t kill him—he shouldn’t be sad to leave anything behind.

He knew the risks of going into this business.

But, still. It was sad to think.

Katsuki glanced at Izuku through the mirror, and caught the look of pity. Quickly, Katsuki huffed and shook his head.

“Tch. Don’t look at me like that,” he quickly snapped. “It all just…feels weird, that’s all.”

Izuku hugged him tighter. “Weird’s allowed.”

Katsuki didn’t answer.

He sat there, watching the mist drift over his apartment. And as they did, the city and all its ghosts felt distant. But with Izuku’s touch, for once, the silence didn’t ache.

“Alright,” he muttered. “Let’s get the hell outta here before I start crying or some shit.”

Izuku laughed, and the sound cracked the quiet open like sunlight.

And with that, Katsuki kicked the throttle, and they vanished into the city further.

☽ ☽ ☽

The hum of the metropolis subdued by the time they found the night market.

Above them, red lanterns swayed lazily from thin strings overhead. Their orange glow spilled across the wet pavement. Lining the narrow passages was steam wafting up from food stalls. The smoke curled into the dark sky like breath on cold glass.

Taking a big inhale, Katsuki savored the delicious smell of grilled meat, soy, sugar, and rain.

He parked the bike near a row of shuttered shops and swung his leg over. Izuku followed, tugging his goggles off and shaking out his damp curls. His cheeks were flushed, and his eyes were glowing with a kind of wonder Katsuki hadn't seen on his face in so long.

"This place is open this late?" Izuku asked.

Katsuki smirked and shoved his hands into his jacket. "It's Yokohama. The food doesn't sleep here."

Izuku grinned, and together they started walking towards the crowds.

The number of people out was light this time of night. It was mostly couples and late-night workers grabbing a last bite. Oil popped. Music crackled faintly from an old radio perched beside a dumpling cart. Vendors called out from behind their sizzling grills and the overlapping words all blurred together: *Takoyaki! Yakitori! Taiyaki!*

Izuku tilted his head, eyes darting everywhere. "It's been years since I've been to one of these casually."

"Yeah?" Katsuki asked, stepping closer as someone brushed past them.

Izuku nodded, the sweetest smile curving his lips. "My brother Hiryu used to bring me to the ones near Tokyo Station. We'd get taiyakis together whenever we hung out."

Katsuki scoffed, but the sound wasn't mocking. "Figures. You're such a sweets guy."

Izuku shot him a fake offended look. "What's wrong with sweets?"

"Nothing. Just means I'm stuck eatin' all the real food myself."

He grinned when his fiancé frowned playfully. He turned ahead, and then straightened when a specific area caught his attention. With an excited step, he tugged Izuku towards the nearby stall. The vendor smiled at them and gestured to the skewers of spicy chicken rotating over the open flame.

Katsuki ordered five. The vendor peeled them off and handed them to him on a paper tray piled high.

"Fuck yeah," Katsuki grinned. "This is what I call real food."

Izuku watched him take a bite of one with a laugh. His eyes lit up with amusement.

"You always go straight for the spiciest thing, don't you?" Izuku joked.

"'Course," Katsuki said around a mouthful of food. "If it doesn't hurt, it's not worth eatin'."

Izuku shook his head, snickering softly. "You have to eat more than spicy food."

"Spicy food is the only food I care about." Katsuki tore off another bite, chewed, and glanced over. "Go on, pick something out. My treat."

Izuku hesitated when Katsuki pulled out his wallet and handed it to him.

“Oh. Kacchan, you don’t have to—”

“Didn’t ask if I had to,” Katsuki interrupted, jutting his chin toward the row of dessert stands. “Pick one before I decide for you.”

After a playful glare, Izuku gave in. He took the wallet and wandered towards a pastel stall selling taiyaki.

Katsuki smiled as he walked behind him. He watched as Izuku eyed one of the fish-shaped pastries. He observed Izuku order. And it was too damn amusing how his fiancé grinned shyly at the old woman behind the counter. It should be criminal how adorable Izuku was with the way his fingers brushed his hair back whenever he got flustered.

When Izuku returned with two taiyaki in hand, Katsuki couldn’t help but grin.

“You look like a kid in a candy store,” Katsuki teased.

“Ah, I feel like one,” Izuku said, voice soft. He held out one of the taiyaki. “Here. Try it.”

Katsuki raised a brow but took it anyway. He took a defiant bite, and the sweetness melted against his tongue.

Instantly, he made a face. “Bleh. Too damn sweet.”

Izuku chuckled, unguarded. In return, Katsuki grinned before he even realized it.

They moved through the narrow aisles, stopping for takoyaki and grilled corn. They ate until they were full and grabbed carbonated drinks in glass bottles. As they wandered through the market, every so often, Izuku’s fingers brushed Katsuki’s. Once. Then twice. Then finally, he slipped his hand into Katsuki’s.

“Still acting shy around me, huh?” Katsuki teased. “You don’t have to, y’know. I won’t bite you, I swear.”

“I know,” Izuku replied, hiding his blush a bit. “I can’t help it. You make me feel…*fuzzy* every time we’re together.”

Validation swelled. “You make me feel fuzzy too.”

They continued to walk like that, hand in hand, beneath the glow of lanterns. Laughter from nearby couples carried to them like music. Katsuki bought more food than either of them could eat. He refused to let Izuku go without trying everything his pretty green eyes set their sights on.

At one point, they paused near a stand selling tiny trinkets. The vendor showed them all their handmade charms that were shaped like tiny, annoyingly adorable animals.

Izuku's eyes sparkled as he picked one up. It was a small brass cat curled around an orange marble.

"This one looks like you, Kacchan," Izuku said with a wide smile.

Katsuki frowned, but the tips of his ears went pink. "Yeah? I thought I was more of a dragon type."

"A cat is better," Izuku said. "Much cuter."

Katsuki barked a laugh. "Cute, huh? You've got me mixed up with someone else."

But when they moved on, Katsuki reached into his pocket and quietly paid for the charm.

Later, when the sky was clear of any rain clouds, they sat on the curb at the edge of the market. The city lights shimmered off the puddles at their feet. And their legs stretched out with the remnants of their feast spread beside them. Between them, various skewer sticks, empty wrappers, and half drained soda bottles laid out as they both took tiny bites of the last pieces of food they were finishing off.

Izuku leaned back on his hands and exhaled. His eyes drifted upward toward the starry sky.

"I see why you loved living here, Kacchan," he said quietly. "It's nice. Thank you for taking me around."

Katsuki turned to him. His gaze caught on the curve of Izuku's jaw illuminated by the lantern glow and the rain still clinging to his curls.

"You needed it," he said simply.

"But so did you."

Izuku gave him a solemn smile.

Katsuki returned the gesture. He wordlessly turned his attention to the discarded trash on the sidewalk and picked it up. With a grunt, he rose and placed it in the nearby trash. As he wandered back to his seat, his stare roamed over the market in front of him. For a moment, the noise of the crowds fell away. All he could hear was just the soft rustle of the wind and the faint hiss of rain in the distance.

When he sat back down, the radiance of Izuku's hand found him again.

Katsuki didn't say anything. He just squeezed back.

And when Izuku scooted in towards him and rested his head against his shoulder, Katsuki thought, for just a second, that maybe the world wasn't such a bad place after all.

Izuku broke the quiet. "So…fate, huh?"

Katsuki scrunched his nose. "Oh, don't start with me, nerd."

“But you believe in it now?” Izuku asked, smile growing wider. “I may have been half dead but I heard that loud and clear.”

“Yeah, but don’t go making a big deal out of it,” Katsuki said. “It’s just—shit like this doesn’t happen for no reason, right? Running into you over and over, and ending up together. And this…” He gestured vaguely at the market and the night sky. “It’s too damn perfect to be a coincidence.”

Izuku snuggled in further. “So you think we were meant to find each other?”

Katsuki let out a chuckle. “I don’t know about all that fairytale crap,” he said. “But yeah…I think we were.” He leaned his head against Izuku’s and the smell of sweet dango wafted into his nose. “Guess I’d be an idiot not to admit it.”

“That’s a rare sentiment to hear from you, Bakugou Katsuki.”

“Don’t push it,” Katsuki warned warmly.

His arm shifted, sliding around Izuku’s back until his palm rested just above his waist.

“Y’know.” Izuku gazed up at him with those big doe eyes. “My opinion on fate has changed a lot too.”

“Oh, yeah? In what way.”

“I used to think fate meant that everything was written,” Izuku explained. “I thought that it was comforting to believe things were out of my control. It made it easier to accept I couldn’t do anything about my circumstances. But maybe…maybe fate is calling you to action. Maybe fate is that some people are drawn to each other. And they will consistently be drawn to each other until they do something about it.”

“Yeah, that sounds right,” Katsuki agreed. “I guess the universe is just going to keep throwing us together until we figure it out.”

Izuku’s fingers brushed against his arm, tentative at first, then firmer. He looped his arm around Katsuki’s sleeve.

“Do you think we’ve figured it out?” Izuku asked.

“Not fully,” Katsuki replied thoughtfully. “But I think we’re close. Hard not to believe I’m on the right path when a crazy, green-haired nerd keeps crashing back into my life every time I turn around.”

Izuku turned his head, smiling against his shoulder. “You think I’m crazy?”

“The good kind. My kind of crazy.”

Izuku looked up at him then, affectionately. “Then I guess that makes you my type of crazy too.”

Katsuki pretended to look away when his cheeks colored red. “Tch. I better be.”

They stayed like that, shoulder to shoulder. The night wrapped around them and Katsuki took the time to soak in his surroundings. The lanterns swaying. The people laughing. And somewhere in the noise, Katsuki felt the weight of fate again.

It was that strange, unshakable certainty that every failure, every fight, and every turn of bad luck, had been leading them right here.

☽ ☽ ☽

The next morning came wrapped in a dull gray sky.

It was the kind of late winter weather that promised sleet but never followed through. The wind was extra fierce and the barren trees rustled a bit harder than usual.

The night market’s laughter and lantern lights faded into memory. The previous sounds were now replaced by the rustle of zippers, the dull thud of luggage, and the metallic rattle of the minivan’s back door.

Katsuki helped hoist one of the duffel bags inside, then wiped his hands on his jeans. He exhaled loudly, breath misting faintly in the cool air.

“Argh, this all feels gloomy,” Denki muttered as he slammed the passenger door shut. “It’s *way* too quiet. It’s like the world knows it’s the end of an era.”

“Don’t start getting poetic,” Sero warned, bumping Denki’s shoulder with his. “You’re not built for it.”

Denki gasped, hand over his heart. “You wound me.”

“You’ll live,” Sero shot back with a grin.

Monoma snorted from where he was, perched against the car. “He won’t, actually. He’ll just talk about it for the next hour.”

“I heard that,” Denki called.

“You were meant to,” Monoma replied smoothly, the corner of his mouth twitching upward.

Sero laughed under his breath and zipped up the last of the gear bags. “Feels like old times already. One big dysfunctional road trip at the end of a big assignment.”

Shinsou, who was leaning next to Monoma, muttered, “Except this time we don’t get to come back together.”

That stilled everyone for a second. Even Denki looked away, his usual cheerfulness dissipating.

Katsuki rolled his shoulders and tried to shrug off the sadness.

“Don’t start making it sound like a damn funeral, guys,” he said. He walked up to Shinsou and firmly patted him on the shoulder. “We’re getting on a boat, not dying.”

“As far as you know,” Monoma said dryly. “You’re heading into international waters. Who the hell knows what’s going to happen.”

“Thanks for the vote of confidence,” Katsuki grumbled.

Izuku glanced up from his snack packing, a gentle smile tugging at his mouth. “We’ll be okay,” he said reassuringly. “Really. Nana is good at what she does.”

“Yeah, you better be,” Miruko agreed, smirking again, but her eyes didn’t quite match the tone. “After all this trouble, you two owe us a happy ending.”

“I agree!” Denki pointed a finger at them. “No dying, no disappearing, and no sending cryptic postcards! I can’t handle emotional suspense.”

“Or emotions in general,” Monoma quipped.

Denki cut his eyes at Monoma and narrowed them down. “You never pass up a moment for a smart ass remark, do you?”

Monoma grinned from ear to ear. “Absolutely not.”

The two of them carried on, and in the midst of the bickering, Katsuki leaned against the van. He half-listened and half-watched. He didn’t want to admit he was going to miss this stupid shit. The roundabout fighting. The sarcastic remarks. Never in his life did he think he’d get accustomed to all these imbeciles—but he had.

His gaze softened as he watched all the different things occurring. Izuku laughed softly beside Sero. Miruko bumped shoulders with Shinsou, trying to cheer him up. And Monoma and Denki went back and forth about something absolutely pointless.

It all made him smile.

Katsuki sighed.

Damn. When did he get so soft?

“Bakugou,” Aizawa called, voice even as ever. “Come here, I got something for you.”

Katsuki turned, frowning as Aizawa gestured him towards the trunk of the minivan. He followed, leaving behind all the others. When Katsuki joined Aizawa at the back end, his ex-supervisor turned to him with a contemplative stare.

“I’ve spent the last few weeks tying up your loose ends,” Aizawa said evenly. “The Bakugou Estate’s been transferred to one of my aliases—I’ll make sure the gravesite stays tended and quiet. Your apartment’s cleared out, sold to a new buyer. And…” He reached into his coat, pulling out a folded document. “I filed an official death certificate. Bakugou Katsuki—deceased by suffocation. You’re legally dead.”

For a moment, Katsuki didn't know what to do.

Honestly, he was banking on the cities foreclosing his properties. He didn't exactly have the means or time to sell his stuff. Mainly because he didn't want to confirm the 'Bakugou Katsuki is back from the dead' rumors. Just in case the Yakuza were monitoring records from his legal name—but of course.

Aizawa had handled it like a pro, exactly like he always did.

"You didn't have to do that," Katsuki muttered.

"I know," Aizawa said. "That's why I did. I also figured you'd want to keep some things."

He stepped forward then and zipped open one particular duffel bag he brought this morning. Aizawa moved aside so Katsuki could see better.

And he nearly couldn't believe his eyes. Inside, stacked neatly, were old photo albums, notebooks, and classical music vinyls he had collected over the years.

But right on top of the pile was a photograph.

It was him and his mom—the year she died.

They were standing in a park side by side. Sunlight poured diagonally across the photo. In Mitsuki's hands was a fresh bundle of pink carnations and the grin on Katsuki's face was relaxed and happy. Katsuki stared at it for a long time, thumb brushing the edge of the frame.

His voice came out quieter than he intended. "You found this?"

Aizawa nodded. "And some others from the estate. They were hidden away but I figured you might like to keep all your family photos."

Katsuki rifled through the bag and froze.

Inside were the photographs he'd taken down from the estate long ago. Sepia-tinted faces of relatives he'd never met stared back at him: his grandparents next to a youthful version of his mother. Nestled among these photos were newer ones too. Pictures from his mother's old apartment. He recognized them because they were the ones he'd stuffed into a box after her death and never opened again.

As he thumbed through them, the years unfolded. Shots of sunlit beaches, quiet parks, and even a few candid ones taken at The Company, with Aizawa standing beside him.

"Thanks," Katsuki rasped, clearing his throat. "Really."

Aizawa didn't reply. Instead, he reached into his coat pocket and pulled out a small wrapped parcel.

"One more thing," he said, handing it to him.

Katsuki took it and then unwrapped it. The tears he was trying his best to keep at bay punched through his eyes then.

It was his baby feet plaster. And it was exactly how he remembered it, repaired by Izuku's hands with the gold lining holding the tiny pieces together. He peered around to Izuku, who was talking with Denki completely unaware. Katsuki smiled. He tried to laugh off the tears and stubbornly wiped them away with the back of his hand.

He sighed and shook his head. "You sentimental old man."

"I know. Sometimes I just can't help it."

Aizawa laughed lightly and shook his head too. He patted Katsuki on the shoulder and then smiled at him. He nodded once and zipped back up the duffel bag. When he closed the trunk he walked towards the driver's side.

"Let's get a move on, Bakugou. We have a long journey ahead of us."

Katsuki nodded, and then watched as Aizawa herded everyone into the car. One by one all the others piled in with Miruko in the passenger seat, Denki, Sero, and Shinsou in the back and Izuku and Monoma in the middle.

For a long moment, Katsuki stayed where he was.

He waded there, knee deep in his own memories. The wind tore through the empty courtyard, threading its cold fingers through his hair. He turned toward the horizon and looked out to the sleepy skyline of Yokohama.

He held the small plaster cast in both hands. His thumb traced across its smooth surface. The item was warm from his touch, as if he were still holding on to a fragment of his mother's warmth. When he lifted his eyes, he could particularly see her there. Her smile was in the passing clouds, and her love was above in the sun that peaked through the cloudy day.

He understood then why his chest hurt so much.

He would miss this place because it was the last piece of her he had left.

The memories flashed through his mind like an old flip book. They were quick and imperfect but achingly vivid. Every street corner he'd shown Izuku carried a ghost of her.

She was there in a faded outline. Her silhouette had been waiting outside his high school gates, waving him over after class sometimes. She was there in the restaurant's dim glow, where the owner slipped him free drinks. They'd sit side by side, sharing karaage as they small talk about nothing and everything. And she was there too, in his old apartment, with a gentle pride in her eyes whenever she'd visit. She'd seen the person he'd become despite her shortcomings.

Katsuki bittersweetly gazed at the sunrise.

He had officially outgrown this place, hadn't he?

“Kacchan!” Izuku’s voice broke the stillness. “Kacchan, c’mon! It’s time to go!”

“Yeah, coming!” Katsuki called back.

With one last look, Katsuki lifted two fingers and subtly saluted the skyline. The wind carried the gesture away, scattering it through the streets and rooftops that had raised him.

He said goodbye to the city he used to call home.

Chapter End Notes

Let me know what you think!

I'm so sorry I haven't been able to get around to respond to comments like normal. August through November is busy season for my field so I'm a little slammed currently :')

Thank you all so much for reading!!

Chapter 51: Semplice

Chapter Summary

> Semplice (musical direction) — To instruct a musician to play simple and straightforward

Chapter Notes

> Hellooo!! :)) Welcome back to this choochoo train!! I come baring another chapter for you! First, big thank you to the LOML, Luna, for betaing like always and second thank you to all of you for reading!! <3 I hope you enjoy this fluffy chapter. I am very surprised at myself for how fluffy it is. Seems like there's some light inside this angsty heart of mine after all :'D

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 51 — Semplice

.

.

.

Pleasant, calming air poured into his lungs.

Katsuki closed his eyes and let the wind roll over him. He had his head leaned out the window, and the breeze was brushing through his hair and stinging his cheeks. But it didn't feel bad. It felt nice because the air had shifted. It was warmer now. Nimble and salt tinged, carrying the distant smell of the southern sea.

Next to him, his future husband rested. Izuku's eyes were closed as the breeze combed back his curls. And his expression was lazy and untroubled.

Around them, the van was rumbling down the highway. Aizawa was at the wheel with his sunglasses perched on the bridge of his nose. The light caught across the windshield as he sang under his breath.

Beside him in the passenger seat, Miruko sat with one foot propped on the dashboard. She was drumming her fingers to a generic pop song Denki and Sero were massacring in the

back. All the while, Monoma's dry interjections poked fun at their pitchy voices. His remarks only fueled their group's laughter as Shinsou slept soundly, somehow.

Izuku's smile caught the light as the road curved. Ahead, the horizon opened wide before them.

They passed by a number of places Katsuki had taken for granted. Green scenery. Magnificent mountains. Even some half frozen rivers showed him their beauty, as if giving him a parting gift.

"Wow," Katsuki said in awe. "I wish we had picked up another disposable camera. We're missing out on some good shots."

Izuku turned to him. "We'll make up for it when we get to our new home."

"I'm holding you to that," Katsuki chuckled.

He returned his attention to the terrain obscuring by in washes of color. Gray towns gave way to olive hills, then to open stretches of sapphire coastline. Above, the sky steadily cleared. It broke open with patches of pale blue that gave an early promise of spring.

Without a word, Izuku reached across the seat and slid his hand into his.

Their fingers fit together effortlessly, like they always had.

☽ ☽ ☽

"I swear this thing is leading us straight into the ocean," Aizawa unhappily muttered. He reached forward and fiddled with the GPS. "This can *not* be the fastest route."

"Maybe it has a point," Monoma replied sarcastically. "There's less traffic underwater."

They'd officially been driving for ten hours.

It wasn't the worst, but they were in for a long fucking trip. They were riding smoothly with the windows down, blasting whatever chaotic playlist Denki cobbled together. It was something between punk rock, eighties pop, and a remix of elevator music.

The latter was shit enough to make Shinsou threaten to leap out the window.

"Change it," Shinsou groaned. "For the love of fuck, *change it*."

"I did!" Denki shouted over the wind. "This is Lo-fi Road Trip Vibes!"

"Sounds more like Lo-fi *Torture* Vibes," Sero quipped.

Out of all of them, Izuku seemed the least bit bothered. He chuckled loudly with Miruko at their group's chaos and handed out snacks. He grinned the whole time while unwrapping rice balls and passing around bottles of Pocari Sweat.

When night time fell, Aizawa and Miruko switched seats.

The stars in the sky twinkled ‘hello’ as they began the next half of the trip.

After a couple of hours, everyone but Katsuki dozed off. He was stuck in a car full of intense snoring. It should have annoyed him, *especially* the way Sero fucking sounded, but it didn’t.

Maybe it was because this was one of the few times their unit was at total peace.

It was nice.

Beside him, Izuku’s head was propped on his shoulder. His eyes fluttered open and closed as the van purred steadily. Whenever the car hit a bump, Izuku grumbled. And then Katsuki would murmur something calming that made the dork smile and doze off again.

When the sun rose anew, they pulled over for a brief moment.

The smell of salt from the Seto Inland Sea wafted into his nose, and Katsuki readily breathed it in. As everyone shook out their limbs, Denki was already wide awake and putting together a new playlist.

When they started up again, Sero volunteered to drive. Or rather, he was the only one Aizawa trusted behind the wheel. Izuku had offered, bright-eyed and eager, but Katsuki immediately pressed his hand down before he could finish the sentence. An icy shiver crawled up his spine at the memory of the last time he endured Izuku’s driving. Once was enough.

As they began driving again, the van was surprisingly tranquil. The new lo-fi music that played on the speakers was much, *much*, better than before.

“Glad you take feedback well, Pikachu,” Katsuki said. “This, surprisingly, doesn’t make me feel like my ears are bleeding.”

“I’m a man of adaptability!” Denki replied.

A couple of snickers arose.

By the time they reached Kyushu, Miruko decided they should play a game of ‘I Spy’.

It seemed harmless, so Katsuki figured, why the hell not. But of course, the game quickly developed into chaos when Denki *insisted* that the thing he spied was the ‘crushing weight of shared trauma’.

“That does *not* count,” Monoma chastised. “You can not see that physically.”

“Oh yes I can,” Denki countered. “Look at Bakugou’s frown lines. He’s gotten like four new ones this year alone. Not to mention he has a couple of fresh grey hairs.”

“Fuck off,” Katsuki hissed.

That earned a laugh from the collective group.

As they approached the far side of the country, it was like they'd passed through every season in two days. The air had turned lukewarm, and the scent of salt crept in with every gust of wind. Everyone's laughter came easier now too, like the long awaited welcoming of spring.

When they finally rolled up to the port in Kagoshima, all of them poured out the van like they were survivors of a great odyssey. Each one of them was bleary-eyed, yet triumphant. They stood in the middle of a busy scene, the noise of fishermen clashed with the vendors calling out the morning's catch.

"Roadtrips, good for the heart but bad for the back," Sero hissed as he stretched out his legs.

Katsuki cracked his neck and let out a deep groan. "Too damn true."

Aizawa ushered them down the dock. He guided them towards a cramped pier tucked behind a line of cargo crates.

Waiting there was a small ferry. It was a shade of black that drank in all the light around it. It bore no name on its hull and there were no markings that betrayed its ownership. But all of them knew: it belonged to The Company.

Aizawa went to the cashier stand, wordlessly taking care of paperwork under one of his old aliases. His tone with the dockhand was cordial as they casually caught up in the morning mist.

"Where are we going this time, boss?" The dockhand asked with a hint of humor.

"Okinawa," Aizawa said. "We have some business there to sort out for the day."

"Ohh, another vacation so soon?"

"Something of the sort."

As Aizawa filed them as passengers, the rest of their crew busied themselves with loading the bags aboard. All of their movements were lethargic after two days of nonstop travel. When the last of the duffels were loaded, Katsuki was the first to drop into one of the seats inside the ferry's cabin.

His spine cracked as he leaned back, and a low ripple of pain moved through his body. But there was something deeply satisfying in the exhaustion. It felt earned. He knew when he finally laid down to rest this time—it would be for good.

Izuku sat down next to him as the air filled with diesel. The others climbed into the cabin in ones and twos as they found places to sit. Somewhere above them, the captain called to the crew. And with a rustic whine, the ferry pulled away from the dock.

Izuku leaned forward, with his elbows on his knees. He tilted his head and squinted at the horizon.

"Ah. You can see the island from here," Izuku claimed.

Katsuki followed his gaze.

A faint shape hovered in the mist ahead, barely visible against the brightening sky.

“Huh,” he said. “You’re right. It’s small but it’s there.”

The wind picked up, tugging through their hair. With it came the clean scent of the sea. Izuku smiled thinly, and to Katsuki that smile transcended the light of the sun. He peered around, and saw the same expression reflected in the faces of his team.

Miruko was leaning against the railing, with her hair blowing like silk. Sero and Denki sat shoulder to shoulder, whispering. Monoma and Shinsou were admiring the way the sun danced along the water, eyes reflecting the spots of light.

It was only Aizawa who stood apart.

His eyes were fixed on the distant island, and the sun painted his face in a muted yellow.

An indecipherable emotion passed across his face.

☽ ☽ ☽

By the time they reached the heart of Okinawa City, the sun was dipping low again. The horizon became progressively painted in streaks of rose and orange above their heads, and Katsuki wondered if this was the last sunset he’d ever see in Japan.

They wandered the city streets with their bags slung over their shoulders. Exhaustion clung to everyone’s bones, but a rare harmony guided all their steps. The endless skyscrapers unfolded before them, accompanied by hundreds of concrete avenues lined with luminous street lamps.

Funny to think this place was the beginning of it all.

“I’m going to have to come back here for my vacation,” Denki said as they passed by some palm trees. “I can see why you two fell in love here. It is *sooo* romantic.”

“Just make sure you stay away from any pink colored resorts,” Katsuki grumbled back.

He adjusted the strap of his duffel as they wove through the crowd. Their group moved like a small current against the tide of people. In the commotion, there was a quiet awareness woven throughout everything. It was as if they all were silently recognizing the full circle.

“What was the alias of the place called again?” Denki asked.

“Lone Flora,” Shinsou replied, scanning the signs above each doorway. “It should be close. We came this way last time.”

They passed small restaurants, a street musician playing piano, and a cluster of kids chasing each other with sparklers in their hands. The deeper they went into Okinawa City, the thicker the crowds became. Right when Katsuki thought they’d turned the wrong way, they finally stumbled upon a small, unassuming alley.

“That’s it,” Miruko said, nodding toward it.

The door was inconspicuous. It was a dull violet against a wall of worn grey stone. A single overhead light flickered faintly, casting long shadows across the pavement. Above it hung a sign painted with the faint outline of a flower curling around the words ‘Lone Flora’.

Aizawa stepped forward first and knocked twice.

A moment later, a metal slit scraped open with a sharp sound. A pair of scrutinizing eyes peered out from the darkness within.

“Sorry, we’re closed for the night,” the man declared plainly. “Come back tomorrow.”

Aizawa exchanged a brief glance with Katsuki, then said clearly, “We’re here for One For All.”

For a passing second, nothing happened. Then the slot snapped shut, and the sound of a heavy lock sliding back echoed through the alley. The door creaked open, and a warm golden light spilled out.

The man on the other side jerked his head. “Hurry.”

They slipped in one by one. And the moment the last of them crossed the threshold, the door slammed shut, cutting off the street’s chaos as cleanly as a blade.

Inside, the air was thick with warmth.

All around, dark brown wood shone. Every surface was polished to a low gleam, and amber light from glass sconces spilled over the leather couches. Across the way, a long mahogany bar sat. It smelled faintly of whiskey and smoke as the bartender served several people. The faint hum of jazz spilled from a gramophone in the corner, mixing with the scent of old wood, candle wax, and cedar. Languidly clung to everything, giving the place an easy intimacy.

Katsuki mouthed ‘wow’ to himself, and Denki gave a low whistle.

A few heads turned their way, quietly assessing them. Some patrons looked startled, shrinking back into themselves. Others, who were rougher around the edges, leaned back in their chairs and scowled.

The man who had opened the door appraised them rigorously. He was a tall guy with bright red hair and a quiet, composed face. Once they all seemingly passed whatever mental test, he gave them a single nod. No words and not a lick of a welcome. He then disappeared through the door behind the bar, without another glance back.

“Talk about a warm welcome,” Monoma murmured.

Miruko shrugged. “They’re probably all on edge. Everyone’s running from something here.”

“Or worse,” Shinsou added. “Some*one*.”

When the red-haired man returned, a new person was walking beside him.

It was a woman. And she perfectly fit the description of Shimura Nana.

She looked nearly identical to the old, shabby photos in the black folder. Strong posture, kind eyes and her presence alone shifted the entire disposition of the room. People who'd been on edge before, relaxed. Safety fell across the whole room.

She stopped in front of their group, and her gaze landed immediately on Izuku.

"You made it," she breathed, relieved.

Before anyone could say a word, she pulled Izuku into her arms. He stumbled for a second and then melted into the embrace with a shaky exhale.

"It's nice to see you again," Izuku said. He smiled fragilely and leaned into the hug. "Sorry it took so long."

Nana laughed against Izuku's shoulder. "It's alright. I'm just glad to see you too."

Izuku's hands trembled as he returned the hug. When they finally pulled apart, Nana cupped Izuku's cheek.

"You've got a few more scars from the last time I saw you," she said. "But I'm glad you're safe."

Izuku laughed and wiped the corner of his eye with the back of his hand.

Nana then turned to the rest of the group, her tone brightening as she greeted everyone. She started with Shinsou, Sero and Miruko. All of whom waved to her, sharing the familiarity of meeting before.

"Nice to see you three again," Nana said with a grin. "Thank you for coming to tell me about the situation. And thank you again for coming now. Izuku is very lucky to have you all."

"It's not a problem at all," Miruko replied. "We're all just glad these two made it out alive."

Then Nana's gaze drifted to Aizawa and Denki.

"Glad to finally meet you after all the phone calls," Aizawa greeted, holding out a hand.

"Likewise," Nana replied, shaking his hand firmly. "Nice to be able to put a face to the voice."

"It's so awesome to meet you, ma'am," Denki interjected, attempting confidence. "My name is Kaminari Denki. Izuku's talked about you a little. You're like, a legend or something! It's really cool."

Nana chuckled. "A legend? I suppose I've been called worse. Thank you."

And then, her eyes met Katsuki's.

He didn't know why the air seemed to thicken in that instant. Or why he suddenly felt so aware of his own posture. He awkwardly cleared his throat, straightened his back, and stepped forward. He reached out a hand, keeping his voice lower than usual.

"Bakugou Katsuki," he said respectfully. "It's, er, an honor to meet you. And…thank you. For waiting for us. Sorry about all the chaos."

Her hand was warm when it closed around his.

"It's not a problem," she said, smiling faintly. "I would've waited as long as it took."

That was when Izuku spoke up.

"Katsuki is the reason I couldn't leave before," he said. He turned toward him, gaze full of love as if the rest of the room had faded away. "I…I couldn't really stomach the thought of leaving him behind."

Katsuki's mouth curved into a genuine smile. Without hesitation, he reached for Izuku's hand, interlacing their fingers.

"It's wonderful to meet you, Katsuki," Nana said. "I've been very excited to see you for quite some time. I understanding that you are going to need help lying low as well?"

"I will," Katsuki replied, slightly embarrassed. "I, uh, also caused a bit of a mess with the Chisakis."

"No worries. I have a no questions asked policy here. You don't have to give me any details. All I need to know is that you're trying to start over and need help." She looked around then with that calm authority. "You must all be tired," she said, and snapped her fingers once.

A pair of men appeared almost immediately. They didn't say a word as they began to collect their bags from them, lifting and taking them over to one of the backrooms.

"Come," she said, her voice warm as candlelight. "Let's get you all something to eat."

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki forgot how much he hated watching Denki eat when he was ravenous.

It was *disgusting*.

"Slow down," Aizawa muttered, barely lifting his eyes from his own plate. "You're going to choke."

Denki mumbled something unintelligible around a mouthful of rice. He sloppily wiped the corners of his lips of grease and gave a thumbs up.

Monoma, sitting across from him, looked personally offended. “Ugh. How can you eat like that? It’s barbaric.”

Denki laughed, spitting out a small bit of food. “It’s delicious, man! And I am starving.”

“Starving or feral?” Monoma muttered with disgust.

Katsuki tried his best to hide his smirk behind a sip of water. Even after everything, some things never changed.

The conversation continued with the usual rowdiness. They were all sitting at a long table in a private lounge room, courtesy of Nana. Beside them, a low fireplace cracked with amber light. It was far too nice for such an unruly group of individuals.

The food, though, was damn delicious. Each of them had been given bowls of curry, rice, and miso soup. On the side, they were even served grilled fish. A full hearty meal that made the air rich with savory flavors. Despite how he *despised* the way Denki inhaled his damn food, he couldn’t disagree with him. This meal was like a warm hug. By the time Katsuki finished his second bowl, Sero was halfway through his fourth.

Suddenly, Nana cleared her throat. Everyone’s eyes turned to her.

She’d been quiet most of the meal, simply watching everyone eat with a satisfied expression. Then she set her chopsticks down and faced Izuku.

“I think we should talk about the kids, Izuku,” she said. “I have some important updates to give you.”

Izuku perked up, blinking in surprise. “Are they all safe?”

She smiled instead of answering. From the folder at her side, she pulled out a thin stack of photos. Their glossy surface caught the light of the fireplace as she passed them to Izuku. He grabbed them hesitantly, clearly unsure of what this could mean. But when he flipped through them, Katsuki felt himself relax.

It was pictures of the families with their kids.

“I was able to reunite them,” Nana said. “The parents give you their thanks for risking your life to bring them back home.”

Izuku’s face lit up. Katsuki leaned closer, watching as Izuku thumbed through the photos one by one.

Each shot showed smiling children. He’d never seen the little brats before, but he could tell they were excited to be with these new people. Each photo showed the tiny humans with adults who looked nearly identical to them. They posed together in backyards with sunlight.

“Thank you.” Izuku laughed under his breath, a sound soft as a sigh of relief. “Thank you so much, Nana. Th-This is all I ever wanted. I don’t even have the right words. Truly, thank you so, so much.”

He flipped through the photos excitedly, memorizing every one. But when Izuku reached a full circle, his smile fell.

He frowned.

He shuffled once more through the stack, searching for something. Right when Katsuki was about to ask what was wrong—it hit him. None of these photos showed Katsuma. The small wide eyed brown-haired boy was nowhere to be seen.

His stomach sank.

“Wait—” Izuku said. He whipped his head up, eyes wide. “Wh-Where’s Katsuma and his family?”

Katsuki’s stomach twisted. The air in the room changed, like someone had cut off the oxygen.

Nana’s smile faltered, and she drew in a slow breath before answering.

“There was…one complication,” she whispered.

Izuku’s voice came out smaller. “What kind of complication?”

“Katsuma’s family was assassinated. All of them. His parents and older sister.”

Katsuki’s fork slipped against his plate, metal scraping too loud in the silence.

Izuku stared. All the color drained from his face. “…They were *murdered*?”

“Unfortunately, yes,” Nana said sadly.

“When did this happen?” Katsuki pressed.

“It happened when Katsuma was about a year old,” Nana continued. Her eyes fell, and her mouth pulled taut. “They’d been looking for their son very intensely. They put out articles, searched every inch of the hospital security footage, and they came very close to finding him. But—they got too close.”

She then pulled two pieces of paper out of her folder and slid them to Izuku.

One was a blog post entitled ‘Children missing from hospitals and Governor of Tokyo’s ties to human trafficking.’ And the second was a newspaper clipping showing obituaries.

“They uncovered something grotesque about the Governor of Tokyo,” Nana said, tapping the document in front of them. “They found some compelling evidence linking him to an underground trafficking ring and went to the police with it. But no one listened. So they put everything they knew online, hoping someone would pick it up.”

She exhaled slowly. “However, the post barely reached anyone. And not long after, their car was T-boned off a mountain road…and then burned with them inside.”

Izuku's face dimmed.

He picked up the tattered newspaper clipping with his fingers. Dejected, teary green eyes looked at the obituary of Katsuma's family. Alongside the text were pictures of two adults and one little girl, smiling.

"Did they catch who did it?" Izuku whispered painfully.

"They did. And I looked into the man responsible," Nana continued. "He was a small-time criminal. He swore someone hired him to take care of the 'problem', but no one believed him. He kept saying the person who paid him called himself 'The Horned Viper'."

Everything froze.

Izuku's eyes widened.

Katsuki's blood went cold.

And a terrible, haunted feeling possessed them.

Nana went on, "The police couldn't find any record of such a person to absolve him. The criminal is rotting away in prison for life."

Silence pooled, thick as tar.

Izuku put down the article and rested his head in his hands. His shoulders dropped, and Katsuki wanted to burn the whole goddamn world. But deep down, he wasn't surprised. Tomura was a cold-hearted motherfucker to the bitter end. Of course, he had no damn issue committing familicide.

"Where…where is Katsuma now?" Izuku asked quietly.

Nana pushed back her chair and stood up.

"That's the part I was saving," she said, her tone lightening.

The whole table went quiet in confusion. Izuku and Katsuki shared a confused glance as she crossed the room. She rested her hand on the handle and then turned back towards them.

"Katsuma didn't want to leave," she explained. "He cried and begged to wait for his big brother. He told me he wanted to wait with me to see if you'd make it back."

Izuku froze.

His eyes widened and his mouth parted as though the words had stolen his breath clean out of him.

And then Nana opened the door.

A small pair of feet shuffled forward from the light spilling in. A boy stepped out, clutching a stuffed rabbit with one arm, the other nervously gripping the doorway. He was smaller than Katsuki remembered from their accidental run-in. And the moment those wide, tear-bright eyes lifted and landed on Izuku, the entire room transformed.

Izuku's chair screeched back as he shot to his feet.

"Katsuma?" His voice cracked, disbelieving.

The boy took off running, tiny sneakers smacking against the floor. The stuffed rabbit nearly flew from his grip as he sped into the room. Izuku met him halfway, dropping to his knees so fast his legs barely caught him. And the sound that came out of him when he pulled Katsuma into his arms was a sigh so loud it captured years of guilt, relief, and hope all collapsing into a single breath.

The boy was sobbing into Izuku's neck, and Izuku sobbed right back into his.

"You came back," Katsuma cried over and over. His little voice shook. "I-I knew you would. You said you wouldn't, but I knew you would."

Izuku laughed through his own tears. One of his hands stroked Katsuma's hair and the other held him as tightly as possible.

"You were right," he whispered hoarsely. "I'm so sorry."

Katsuki swallowed hard, his throat thick. He couldn't remember the last time something had made his chest ache like this. Watching Izuku win after losing so much, felt right.

He glanced around and everyone else at the table was watching on with sentimental, bleary expressions. Behind them, Nana smiled quietly. She had one hand resting over her heart as she looked on as well.

Katsuki couldn't take his eyes off them.

Izuku was still kneeling on the floor, arms wrapped tight around the small boy. Katsuma clung back equally as fierce, his tiny fists balled in the fabric of Izuku's jacket, face buried against his chest.

The two of them fit together so naturally.

It made sense now why Izuku had fought so hard to protect those kids.

Katsuki had always thought it was guilt, and some misplaced sense of duty. But he was wrong. This was love. Pure, unconditional love. It was the kind of love Katsuki used to think people like them weren't capable of.

Izuku lifted his head finally, eyes glassy but shining. He turned towards Nana.

"You've been taking care of him all this time?" His voice trembled in awe.

“It’s been a pleasure. He’s a very polite young boy,” Nana replied, glancing at Katsuma, who was still nestled safely in Izuku’s arms. “I was going to try to find a new home for him, but he insisted he wanted to wait and see if you’d come back. And while we were waiting, I thought it might be best if he went with you two.”

Izuku blinked rapidly. “Go with us? Out of Japan?”

She nodded. “You said your goal was to make sure these children found a place to be loved and safe. I think the best place for Katsuma now is with you. He loves you a lot.”

Izuku’s mouth opened, but no sound came out. Katsuki could see the way his throat bobbed and how his grip on the boy tightened slightly. He looked down at Katsuma again, eyes shimmering.

“What do you think, buddy?” he asked softly. “Would you want to come with me on a new adventure?”

Katsuma leaned back to meet his gaze. “I do! I want to stay with you.”

Izuku’s smile broke out wider. Right as he seemed close to breaking down again, Katsuma’s small hand came up. He brushed at one of the tears slipping down Izuku’s cheek.

“Don’t cry,” Katsuma whispered. “You don’t have to cry anymore. Nana told me we’re going somewhere happy. She said we don’t have to train anymore, and you don’t have to go away for long times again.”

That cracked Izuku completely.

He let out a broken laugh and nodded, trying to steady his breath.

“You’re right,” Izuku said, voice thick but he was smiling now. “I won’t cry. Not anymore.” He pressed Katsuma close again. His words muffled against the boy’s hair. “I’d love to have you come with me.”

Izuku turned to Katsuki then, eyes shining. “Is that alright with you, Kacchan?”

All eyes turned to Katsuki, Katsuma included.

Katsuki rubbed the back of his neck. “Yeah, of course that’s—”

Suddenly, Katsuma shrieked.

The sound tore through the quiet like a siren, and everyone jolted. The tiny boy stumbled behind Izuku, pointing at Katsuki with a trembling finger.

“M-Monster!” Katsuma screamed, clutching Izuku’s shirt. “That’s the monster I saw! With the red eyes!”

Instantly, the room froze. Every head swiveled towards Katsuki in extreme confusion. He groaned and dragged both hands down his face.

Oh, for fuck's sake. He'd forgotten about that.

Izuku blinked between the two of them, baffled. "Katsuma, what are you talking about? He's not a—"

Then Izuku stopped mid-sentence. Katsuki saw the exact second realization dawned on his fiancé. Izuku paused, his jaw twitched, and his head turned excruciatingly slow.

"Fuck me," Katsuki muttered under his breath.

"Kacchan," Izuku said carefully, a flush creeping up his neck. "Was that you he saw outside our window that night?"

A chorus of bewildered cries broke out.

"Outside the *window*?" Sero hissed.

Aizawa groaned and threw his head back. "Please don't tell me this is going where I think it is."

Katsuki winced. He scratched the back of his head. "Yeah. Forgot to mention. But, uh, that was me."

"What the *hell* were you doing peeking into his window?" Miruko snapped. "Oh my god, Bakugou! That's so creepy!"

"I wasn't peeking!" Katsuki yelled, cheeks burning. "I was making sure he was safe! It sounds bad out of context—but I only wanted to talk to him, alright? I didn't have his damn number, so I improvised! I didn't even know the kid was there until it was too late. He's freakishly small!"

"The kid is an ordinary sized child," Shinsou deadpanned.

Denki doubled over, wheezing. "Oh, this is gold! Bakugou is a peeping tom!"

"I'm *not* a peeping tom!" Katsuki barked, glaring at all of them. "It was a misunderstanding. Besides, I even smiled at the little guy—and he still screamed!"

The laughter that followed was merciless. Even Aizawa pinched the bridge of his nose like he was fighting a chuckle.

Izuku looked like he was trying to be serious—but he was failing miserably. His shoulders shook, and his lips pressed together. Then a small snort escaped him, and that was it. He burst into uncontrollable laughter.

"Oh my god," Izuku gasped between giggles, covering his mouth. "Kacchan, you terrified a child with a *smile*?"

Katsuki grumbled something incoherent as his ears turned visibly red. "It wasn't like that."

“It was exactly like that,” Izuku said, still laughing, wiping at his eyes.

He looked down at Katsuma, who was hiding behind him. He was still suspicious but curious now as everyone continued to poke fun at Katsuki.

Izuku pointed to Katsuki. “He’s not a monster. He’s just really bad at talking to people.”

“Hey,” Katsuki warned, but Izuku only motioned him closer.

Katsuki sighed and rose from his seat. He walked over to where Izuku and Katsuma were and squatted down to their level. He met Izuku eye to eye as Katsuma hid further away behind his brother.

“Come on,” Izuku called, rubbing Katsuma’s shoulders. “Kacchan is harmless. I promise.”

Izuku reached out, and before Katsuki could object, he poked his cheek. The sound that escaped Katsuki was an annoyed “oi,” which only made Izuku laugh harder.

“See?” Izuku said, grinning. He ruffled Katsuki’s hair for good measure. “He’s totally human. Just grumpy.”

Katsuma peeked out again. His curious eyes flicked between Izuku’s easy warmth and Katsuki’s forced composure. After a long, hesitant beat, he reached forward. He very quickly poked Katsuki’s cheek too. Then, when Katsuki didn’t growl or explode, Katsuma cracked into a small, uncertain giggle.

Katsuki did his best to smile. “Sorry for frightening you. I promise you can give me one good scare too as payback. I deserve it.”

That made Katsuma smile and say, “Okay!”

He shuffled a little closer to Izuku’s side, still holding onto his shirt, but this time it was more for comfort than protection.

Izuku beamed at both of them.

“There,” he said delicately. “Now you’re officially introduced.”

“Who are the others?” Katsuma asked quietly.

Izuku’s grin stretched. “They’re awesome heroes called M-Unit! Want to meet them? They’re all Kacchan’s friends, and they helped save my life.”

Katsuma nodded, shy but curious. Izuku scooped him up with an easy laugh, rising to his feet. He carried the boy from one person to the next, making warm introductions all around.

Miruko was ecstatic. She practically bounced as she ruffled Katsuma’s hair. After her, Denki looked like he met his new favorite human. Even Aizawa’s expression relaxed fully. His mouth tugged upwards before he could stop it.

While the room filled with light chitchat, Katsuki slipped back into his seat between Izuku's empty chair and Monoma. He exhaled. The lingering burn on his cheeks faded as the noise and warmth of the group filled the room.

He caught sight of Izuku kneeling beside Shinsou. Both of them were praising Katsuma for being so well mannered. The kid's grin was wide and bright. And even Shinsou, who acted like smiling was a crime, looked genuinely charmed.

Katsuki glanced away for a moment.

There was something about seeing Izuku like this that made his chest too full.

Izuku had always been kind-hearted. His fiancé was stubbornly selfless and affable to a fault. But watching him cradle a child who saw him as the center of the world, painted him in a new light. Izuku was someone who could love so deeply that it reshaped the world around him.

Katsuki let out a slow breath and leaned back in his chair. He reached for his cup of water and took a sip, trying not to get too emotional.

Monoma, watching the whole thing, sighed beside him. "Wow, man."

Katsuki shot him a look. "What?"

Monoma smirked. "Congrats on becoming a father."

Katsuki choked on his water.

☽ ☽ ☽

He sat in silence, eyes fixed across the lounge on Izuku and Katsuma.

The two were in the middle of the room, surrounded by the others. Katsuma was proudly showing off his new toy collection. It was a bunch of gifts Nana had bought him in the last few months. And Izuku, ever the perfect big brother, fawned over every single stuffed animal like they were treasures.

The rest of M-Unit played along, offering exaggerated praise that made Katsuma's eyes shine. The sparkle in his eye was that rare, delicate kind of wonder only kids could still have.

Katsuki exhaled, sinking deeper into the couch beside Monoma. It hit him like a goddamn baseball bat to the side of the head. He and Izuku were going to be responsible for a small child. A tiny, breakable, *impressionable* small child.

Holy. Shit.

"You alright?" Monoma asked from beside him.

Katsuki blinked, slow. "Yeah. I'm fine."

Monoma tilted his head, unconvinced. “If something’s on your mind, now’s the time to say it.”

Katsuki opened his mouth to tell him to mind his own damn business. But then he stopped. Across the room, Katsuma laughed. It was a cute, bubbly sound that didn’t belong in the kind of world Katsuki knew.

He felt like an intruder simply watching Izuku and Katsuma play together.

“I don’t want to accidentally fuck the kid up,” Katsuki confessed quietly. “Izuku went through all this trouble to get the kids out of danger and now…” He sighed and rubbed the back of his neck. “I dunno. I never thought about raising a kid. My childhood doesn’t exactly scream ‘will make a good role model’. I don’t have a damn clue what to do with a child.”

Monoma gave a thoughtful hum.

“You’ll be fine,” he said, patting Katsuki on the shoulder. “Stop being so melodramatic. Izuku clearly knows what he’s doing. And honestly? You’re not as bad as you think.”

Katsuki snorted. “Not that bad? That’s rich coming from you.”

“I know,” Monoma chuckled. “But you’ve proven me wrong more than once, and I’m not too proud to admit it. You’re not as bad as I thought you were.”

“Only slightly bad, then?” Katsuki muttered.

Monoma smirked. “No. Not bad at all. The truth is, I thought we were too similar when we first met. I know how fucked up I am, so maybe I projected that onto you. It’s hard to trust someone who reminds you of yourself when you don’t even trust yourself.”

Katsuki tore his gaze away from Izuku and turned to look at Monoma.

His long-time colleague wasn’t smirking anymore.

“I can admit I was a bit harsh,” Monoma continued. “But what I’m saying is—you’ll be fine. You already know exactly what *not* to do with a kid. That alone puts you ahead of most people.”

Katsuki let out a breath that was half a laugh.

“Thanks,” he muttered. “Didn’t know you had a heart in there.”

“I let it out sometimes,” Monoma said dryly, shrugging. Then, with a crooked grin, he said, “But I expect at least one Christmas card with the three of you posing like some corny, happy family in matching onesies.”

Katsuki groaned and rolled his eyes. “Fine. Whatever.”

But he didn’t stop the small, reluctant smile that crept up on him.

Suddenly, the creak of a door drew everyone's attention.

They all turned and saw Nana step out from the back room. A small bag was slung over her shoulder, and a child-sized coat was folded neatly in her arms. The bag looked modest, but it was packed full of Katsuma's clothes.

Katsuki watched as she crossed the room. She crouched in front of the small boy, setting the coat aside just long enough to pull him into a firm hug. Katsuma wrapped his arms around her neck, whispering something only she could hear.

Behind them, Izuku started gathering the boy's new toys. He carefully packed them into one of the duffel bags. He moved gently, making sure not a single stuffed animal was left behind. Around them, the others had gone quiet, watching with an unspoken understanding.

"The boat's ready," Nana said finally. "We need to head out soon if we're going to stay on schedule. I got all your arrangements set to go."

Katsuki took a slow breath. "Time to get a move on, I guess."

Beside him, Monoma stood too. He brushed off his hands and stretched as if he were shaking off the weight in the air. Katsuki followed his lead, his gaze locked on Izuku and the boy in his arms.

"You're going to do great," Monoma whispered. "I believe in you."

Izuku turned towards him then, with Katsuma perched comfortably on his hip. His green eyes met Katsuki's, and a faint, tired smile stretched across his beautiful face. He walked up to him and reached out, taking Katsuki's hand in his free one.

"Are you ready, Kacchan?" Izuku asked patiently.

Katsuki squeezed his hand once. "I am."

☽ ☽ ☽

The night air hung heavy with dew. It clung to Katsuki's coat and curled low across the ground as they trekked down the gravel path.

Their group moved in near silence.

No chatting. No laughing. Only the steady rhythm of their footsteps and the distant whisper of the tide calling to them. Street lamps glowed faintly along the path, halos of white light that flickered in the damp air. Every breath came out as a pale wisp, vanishing as soon as it met the dark.

Beside him, Izuku strolled peacefully. Their hands were intertwined, and Katsuma was still perched on his hip, bundled up. The kid's head rested against Izuku's shoulder, half-asleep.

A few paces ahead, Nana led the way with some of her crew.

Trailing behind them were the stragglers. There were exactly six people who hadn't made the first escape with Nana's prodigy, Yagi. They had barely missed the deadline and were forced to wait for the next dispatch.

Right when Katsuki assumed no one was going to speak on their walk, out of the quiet, one straggler spoke. She was a woman with streaks of gray in her hair and a blue scarf wound tightly around her neck. She turned and looked toward Izuku and Katsuki.

"You don't know me, but I feel the need to thank you both," she said sincerely. "If you hadn't been late, I wouldn't have made it out of the situation I was in. It was really a miracle in disguise."

Izuku gave her a kind smile. "Glad it worked out for all of us."

The woman nodded faintly before falling back in line.

They kept going and the silence returned. But it felt different now. It was nice to know other people benefited from their chaos. All the pain they had endured didn't only take lives, it had inadvertently saved some too.

As they crested the final hill, the dock came into view.

It was bathed in the pale shimmer of moonlight. The dark water reflected everything like glass and there, moored to the end of the wooden planks, was their ship.

It was massive. Three decks at least. Its steel frame caught faint glints of silver from the night sky. Painted along the side in sweeping white letters were two words: Lone Flora.

When they finally got to the end of the dock, everyone gathered on board. The stragglers went first. They all neatly piled on with their bags and hollowed out eyes. Behind them, the whole of their unit paused. They waited there, staring at the large ship meant to take them away.

Katsuki inhaled deeply.

This was it.

Hope flickered in his eyes.

Izuku stood close to Katsuki. Their fingers were laced so tightly it was impossible to tell whose hand was trembling. But if Katsuki had to guess, it was his own. His usual stoicism cracked enough to show the heaviness he was feeling.

Fuck. He was not good at goodbyes.

And from the looks of it, he wasn't alone. He speculated that's what happened when everyone was violently inclined and emotionally constipated. Shinsou rubbed his neck. Sero worked his jaw. Miruko found it hard to meet anyone's eyes. And Monoma awkwardly kicked at the dock once and pressed his lips together.

Denki was the first to break the silence.

“So,” he said. He forced a grin that didn’t quite stick. “You two finally get to live the post-hitman career dream, huh? You’ll probably go somewhere where it’s all sunshine, waves, and coconut drinks with those dumb umbrellas.”

Izuku laughed. “You could always visit.”

“Yeah,” Denki replied, eyes flicking away. “We will. Once things cool down.”

Monoma crossed his arms. His tone was prickly but still more amiable than anyone had ever heard it. “Try not to get yourselves killed again. It’s exhausting having to emotionally recover every time one of you nearly dies.”

Katsuki grinned. “Is that a confession of you caring?”

Monoma’s glare flickered into a reluctant smirk. “Closest you’ll get.”

Miruko stepped forward next. “You better take care of each other,” she said, jabbing a finger at both of them. “And Bakugou, don’t go getting dull just because you’re retired. Keep your instincts sharp in case someone crazy comes knocking.”

“Of course.” Katsuki gave her a lopsided smile. “Wouldn’t dream of becoming lazy.”

She grinned back. “Good.”

And then, to Katsuki’s surprise, she tugged them both into a tight hug. Izuku’s eyes went wide at the same time as Katsuki’s as she squeezed them.

“You’re both tougher than you think,” she murmured. “Don’t forget it.”

When she stepped back, Aizawa moved in. He looked at them both for a moment, eyes incomprehensible, before resting a hand on each of their shoulders.

“You’ve…uh…You’ve both done enough fighting,” he said rigidly. “Whatever comes next, let it be peace. You both deserve at least that much. And *please*, no more seeking revenge.” He shot Izuku a scolding stare. “From *either* of you.”

They both nervously laughed.

“We won’t, old man,” Katsuki reassured.

Then came Shinsou. He hesitated at first, hands shoved deep in his pockets. His gaze flicked between Izuku, Katsuki and the boat with Nana. He’d been quiet the whole time, doing what Shinsou did best, listening and assessing. But when the stillness fell on the dock, he stepped forward to them both.

“Guess this is it, huh?” He said gently.

Katsuki nodded. “Guess so.”

For a second, it seemed like that would be all. But then Shinsou's jaw tightened. And before either of them could react he put his hand out towards Izuku in a friendly offering. Izuku hesitantly reached out, but then shook his hand. Shinsou firmly squeezed it and cupped it lightly with his other hand.

"It's nice to know this idiot is in good hands," Shinsou said. "Live your second chance at life well, Izuku."

Izuku's wobbly smile filled with happiness. "Thank you."

"And if anyone tries to come for you again," Shinsou added, looking him in the eye, "Call us. We'll be there to come to the rescue again. Bakugou is kinda hopeless without us."

Everyone laughed, and Katsuki scoffed through a chuckle.

When they finally let go, everyone was staring at the water. The hum of the ship filled the silence. Gulls circled overhead, their calls distant.

Katsuki looked at the others, eyes full of fondness.

"You all…" Katsuki began, then stopped. He gave a signature lopsided smirk. "You weirdos made this shitty world survivable. That's all I've got to say."

Aizawa nodded once, eyes glinting. Miruko saluted him with two fingers. Denki and Sero threw up matching peace signs. Monoma rolled his eyes but mirrored them anyway. And Shinsou, standing a step behind, gave a departing nod.

"Let's get you guys loaded up on the boat," Miruko said through her sniffling.

She quickly wiped her face and grabbed one of Katsuki's bags. He tried to stop her, but she was off. Behind her, the others all followed. They all grabbed either a backpack, a duffel, or a suitcase. Izuku took off behind them too, insisting on helping with the heavier items.

In the wake of the commotion, Aizawa and Katsuki stayed on the dock.

The wind blew between them.

Wordlessly, he turned his attention back to the elder man. They both assessed one another in the moonlight as the dark clouds overhead passed by one at a time.

Katsuki stared at Aizawa, and Aizawa stared at him.

The finality hit him, and all he could feel was the push of tears.

"So this is really it," Aizawa said. He nodded slowly, eyes flicking off to the side with a strained smile. He put his hands in his pockets and tried to play it cool. "You've come a long way. I'm glad you somehow made it in one piece."

Katsuki dryly laughed. "Debatable."

“Yeah. I guess…this is where we say goodbye.”

“Feels like we’ve done that a few times already. Maybe we should switch it up. You could yell at me, for old times’ sake?”

“Don’t tempt me,” Aizawa scolded. He tried to find the humor, but the sadness in his eyes was too strong. His usually tired stare was distant, as if Katsuki was already gone. “But this time, the goodbye is for real.”

“But hopefully not for long.”

“Hopefully.”

The discomfort came again, and Katsuki looked over his shoulder. He saw all their bags being loaded up. As he watched, the first crack in his defenses came. His brows furrowed, and his traitorous damn heart became ten times heavier.

He looked at Aizawa again. For real this time. He studied his slouching posture and saw all the burdens he shouldered sitting there. He saw a man who was consistently present, even without being asked, and tried his best to help even when life was bleak.

“Thanks for always putting up with my shit,” Katsuki said awkwardly low.

Aizawa gave a small nod. It was enough to close a chapter—but not enough for Katsuki. Something in his chest rebelled. His pulse spiked, his throat tightened, and before he could stop himself, he shook his head.

“No,” he blurted. “That’s not—” He exhaled sharply, grounding himself, forcing the words to come out right this time. “That’s not all I wanna thank you for.”

Aizawa arched his brow. “Bakugou, you don’t have to get sappy.”

“I do,” Katsuki shot back. He took a step closer. “I actually, *really* do.”

And then, with a kind of raw, unfiltered sincerity that burned straight through his pride, he said it.

“Thank you for looking out for me these last ten years, Aizawa.”

Aizawa’s eyes widened.

He was surprised, but then the first crack in his fortress came. His eyes welled up. Of course, the damn man tried to be tough and write it off. But Katsuki knew, sadness was one of those things you couldn’t hide from. It’d track you down and make you give it recognition. Aizawa’s face crumbled, and he sniffled as he tried to wipe his eyes.

He looked touched. So Katsuki kept going.

“You weren’t perfect,” Katsuki spoke quietly. “But neither was I. And even though I was a pain in the ass, you were always looking out for me. You’re the one who made me stay in

school when I wanted to drop out. You helped me get a proper diet. You took me clothes shopping when you saw the holes in my shoes. You saw every blind spot I couldn't. And every day, you warned me about shit I should've taken more seriously."

Aizawa scoffed a quiet laugh, and Katsuki did too.

His eyes burned, and the words began to stumble out.

"You wanted me to be more than a tragic story," he continued. "And you're one of the reasons I actually think I can be."

Katsuki wiped at his eyes with the heel of his hand, but it didn't help much. Aizawa was looking at him with pure pride. And it made Katsuki feel fourteen again, desperate to prove his life was worth something.

"I hated myself for a long time," Katsuki went on. "Longer than I wanna admit. I hated where I came from. I hated who I was born to. I hated my whole damn life. But you helped me make something out of the mess. You helped me play the shitty hand I was dealt. So…thank you."

He grinned through his tears.

"Thank you for being the closest thing to a dad I'll ever have, old man."

Aizawa's eyes glistened. He shook his head, a laugh caught somewhere between disbelief and love, and wiped at his face. Then, without another word, he stepped forward. He laid a firm hand on Katsuki's shoulder.

For a moment, he stood there.

Then, he pulled Katsuki into an embrace.

Aizawa held him tight, and the tension that had hung between them for years finally melted away. And in their own way, they didn't need any more words. The silence was full of everything they'd never said but always meant.

When they finally pulled apart, Aizawa's expression melted into paternal pride.

"You've always been like a son to me, Katsuki," he said, voice breaking. "And no matter where you end up—or what kind of trouble you drag yourself into—you can always call me. I'll come running…and probably yell at you a bit while I'm at it."

They both laughed.

"I'll miss you, old man."

"And I'll miss you too, kid."

Right as they stepped apart, the others finally returned. All the bags were gone, stowed away somewhere.

“Okay, I think it’s about time for us all to go officially,” Sero said. He stood next to his uncle, and gave Katsuki a wistful look. “Nana says she’s got a schedule, but she doesn’t want to push the farewells.”

Katsuki looked up at the dock of the boat and saw Izuku there holding Katsuma. The tiny, sleepy boy waved at them, and Nana waved too. Izuku smiled at him, nodding at him to take his time.

Katsuki took a deep breath in and glanced at his teammates.

His throat felt tight, but he hid it with a crooked smirk. Then, with a flick of his chin and an overdramatic spread of his arms, he barked out, “If you extras want to be rid of me, I demand a damn group hug. No exceptions.”

That was all it took.

Denki let out a loud whoop and launched himself. He slammed into Katsuki’s side like a golden retriever.

Sero was right behind him, laughing as he threw his long arms around them both. Miruko snorted but didn’t hesitate to shove her way in, nearly toppling all of them backward.

Monoma muttered something about “unprofessional displays of affection,” but his voice cracked halfway through as he joined anyway.

Aizawa followed, dragging his feet and sighing under his breath as if he were above it. But he wrapped an arm around Katsuki’s shoulder in a rare show of warmth. Shinsou stayed on the edge, pretending to adjust his bag until Monoma shot him a small glare. Then finally, with a muttered curse, he stepped forward. He completed the circle as everyone pressed in tighter.

Katsuki felt their heartbeats pass through him. He cherished the steady pulse of people who had made him feel at home.

Then Denki’s voice broke subtle sobs. “I’m so happy we were all migraines together.”

That undid the last of their composure. Sero’s grip tightened around their bundle. Shinsou sniffled and swore it was sea spray. Even Monoma blinked fast, muttering something about sand in his eyes.

Then the hug unraveled slowly. It was as if no one really wanted to be the first to let go.

One by one, they stepped back, leaving Katsuki standing in the middle of the dock. He looked over their unit one last time. No, not a unit. His mismatched, chaotic family.

The boat’s honk blew loudly.

“Guess that’s my cue,” Katsuki sniffled, trying to play it off.

He stepped onto the ramp, boots clanging against the metal. His shoulder stiffened as the crew began to pull up the mooring lines. He looked over his shoulder. Below, his family

stood waving. Aizawa was smiling. Denki was shouting last-minute jokes. And the others were too choked up to speak.

Katsuki raised a hand in farewell.

When he got to the deck of the boat with Izuku, the crew finished prepping to set sail. The boat groaned as it drifted away from the dock, the water parting beneath it. He stood side by side with Izuku, and together, they both waved. They held eye contact with the others as their boat steadily pulled away.

Second by second, the figures onshore grew smaller. And in return, Katsuki's eyes blurred up.

He cried openly the second their voices faded into the wind.

Sob after heartbreaking sob spilled from his lips. He tried to stop it. But he was powerless. It was as if a piece of his heart stayed on that dock, and the hole that it left behind allowed all his pent-up emotions to escape.

Izuku leaned in close. "We'll see them again," he said tenderly and certainly.

"Yeah," Katsuki replied. He sobbed lightly. "I know we will."

☽ ☽ ☾ ☾

Saying goodbye was something Izuku never quite mastered.

But with every loss and every parting, he learned a little more. He had said goodbye to Katsuma once. And then to Katsuki, believing he'd never see him again. He said goodbye to Tomura, his brother who had made him feel a storm of emotions too volatile to name.

And now, he was saying goodbye to the most important people in Katsuki's life—his family.

He watched the way Katsuki carried the farewell in his body. He squared his shoulders as if to make space for the ache and took in a long breath. His chest rose and fell in shuddering waves that mimicked the sea and his tears caught the wind.

But Izuku saw something strangely beautiful on Katsuki's face then. It was the way grief and hope coexisted in his eyes, terrified yet bright all at once.

When the dock finally disappeared from view, Katsuki turned toward the dark horizon. The sea wind rustled his hair, and an expression of freedom Izuku had never seen before took over.

"I feel so light," Katsuki rasped, blinking away the last of his tears. "I feel light in a good way. Is that normal?"

"I don't know," Izuku said honestly. "But I feel it too. Maybe this is what it's like to start over."

And together, hand in hand, they watched the horizon stretch before them, endless and new.

ᔓᔓᔓ

The ship was larger than Izuku expected.

It was lined with countless rooms, cabins, and private lounges that weren't exactly shabby. In front of them, Nana led the way. She guided them through all the halls that were lined with pale lights.

"This is the mess hall," she said, gesturing towards a wide open room filled with tables and benches. "We run it for twenty-four hours. There's food, water, and any medical supplies you may need you can find here."

Izuku peered in quietly. Inside, several tired individuals huddled around a table. They were murmuring low to themselves. Some were bandaged, some were asleep with their heads buried in their folded arms, and a few glanced up at them. They quietly surveyed Izuku, the child on his hip, and Katsuki, who stood behind them with his arms crossed.

Nana's tour continued. She took them all around. First, to a small infirmary. Then she brought them to a storage room lined with crates and life vests. Then to another room cramped full of maps and monitors that buzzed faintly with static.

It was as if every corner of the ship breathed of purpose. And every breath came together to help those who wanted to keep living even when the world turned against them.

When they finally stopped, it was in a quieter room at the end of a corridor. They stood in the center of a small common area lit by the amber glow of a single lamp.

Nana turned to face them. "We'll be at sea for about a month," she informed. "By morning, we'll be out of Japanese territory entirely. And after that, it's pretty much smooth sailing. It'll take two, maybe three weeks for us to reach the first safe harbor." She folded her hands neatly, eyes flicking between Katsuki and Izuku. "Would you two like to be onboarded now or later?"

Katsuki tilted his head. "What does onboarding entail?"

"Logistics," she explained. "We need to get any bank accounts in your name drained and closed. We'll also need to get your new identities registered and your passports fully forged. We have everything we need to do those things back in the main office area."

Izuku pressed his lips together.

He wanted to get everything out of the way, but the sleep on his eyelids was demanding his attention. And when he glanced at Katsuki, he saw the same fatigue written in the slope of his shoulders and the faint droop in his posture.

"We'll come back to it," Izuku murmured. "It's been a long day."

Nana nodded, unsurprised. “Of course. There’s no rush. You’ve both earned a moment to relax.”

Katsuki shifted his weight. “Where’d you find a place for us?”

“Somewhere no one will come looking,” Nana said. Then her expression warmed, eyes crinkling at the corners. “Would you like to know now or later? Some people prefer to keep it a surprise. I find it gives them something to look forward to.”

Izuku looked at Katsuki happily.

“Let’s keep it a surprise,” he said. “That sounds nice.”

Katsuki’s mouth curved in agreement. “Yeah. I like that.”

“Then a surprise it is,” Nana replied with a light laugh. “I always love this part of the journey. Now, why don’t you both get some rest? We’ve got a long ride ahead, so make yourselves as comfortable as you can. I’ll show you to your cabin.”

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku sighed as he sank down onto the mattress.

The day’s exhaustion settled into his bones heavier than gravity. But seeing Katsuma’s peaceful face made him feel a little lighter. The boy barely stirred as Izuku eased him down beside him, his tiny body slack with sleep.

“Thank god you’re a heavy sleeper,” Izuku whispered.

Gently, he pried Katsuma’s fingers free and tucked him under the blanket. He smoothed it over his chest until he looked perfectly cocooned.

When he finally straightened, Izuku let his eyes wander over their cabin.

It was small but warm in its own way. There were two standard sized beds, a nightstand with a lamp, a single bathroom, and a small balcony opening. The metal floor was covered with a plain rug. It held intricate patterns that made the cold room a little less unwelcoming. Their duffel bags were stowed overhead beside neatly folded sheets.

Through the thin curtains in front of the balcony windows, Izuku caught sight of Katsuki. He was standing outside on the balcony. His fiancé was still as stone, elbows propped on the railing. His eyes were fixed on the dark horizon and the moonlight drew sharp edges along his profile.

Izuku stood, feeling the low hum of the ship’s engines through the soles of his shoes. He slipped out onto the balcony and joined him, leaning his arms against the railing until their shoulders brushed.

Together, they looked out at the horizon.

The night was entirely quiet, save for the gentle sound of waves.

“You don’t have to be nervous about Katsuma,” Izuku said. “I can do most of the heavy lifting with him. He’s always been my responsibility anyways.”

“There you go again,” Katsuki half lectured. “Stop trying to take on everything by yourself. Sorry, but that ring on your finger means we split responsibilities. Katsuma is half mine now too.”

“Really?” Izuku whispered. “You don’t mind at all?”

“Of course not.” Katsuki smiled tiredly. “How could I with the way you two look at each other? Your face lit up brighter than the damn sun when you saw him. I wanna see that everyday.”

“I’m glad you don’t mind, Kacchan. I think you two will really like each other.”

Katsuki exhaled, breath fogging faintly in the cold.

“You know,” he said in a whisper, “I never considered potentially helping raise a kid. If I do something that could be a bad influence, let me know. Maybe I should buy a couple of those parenting books and sign up for some classes.”

“You really thought this through,” Izuku said a bit cheekily.

Katsuki laughed. “I just want to avoid passing down any of my fucked up traits. And y’know, I’ve always been pretty fucking against shrinks and all that shit.” He paused, glancing sideways to meet Izuku’s gaze under the pale light. “But maybe when we get where we’re going, a shrink wouldn’t be bad.”

“The proper term is therapist, Kacchan,” Izuku said gently. “Shrink is kind of outdated.”

Katsuki clicked his tongue and rolled his eyes, though there was no real bite in it.

“Whatever, nerd. My point is, I wanna be better. I want to be the best version of myself from now on. Not just for you, but for me too. And for Katsuma now as well.” He jerked his chin toward the small figure sleeping inside. “We all deserve to live as the best versions of ourselves.”

“Okay, we can do that,” Izuku agreed. “I like that idea a lot.”

Katsuki caught Izuku’s hand and laced their fingers together. He pulled Izuku closer until their foreheads nearly touched. When they were near enough for their heartbeats to find the same rhythm, Katsuki wrapped his arms around him.

“Also,” Katsuki whispered, “if you ever get thoughts like the ones you had when you took the poison—tell me. *Please*.” His eyes searched Izuku’s. “I’ll be here for you, no matter what. Tell me what you need, when you need it or how you need it. I’ll drop *everything* for you.”

Izuku's eyes welled up. His throat tightened. "I will. I'm sorry for scaring you like that."

Katsuki brushed a strand of hair from his face.

"You don't have to be sorry," he murmured. "I just want you to live the way you deserve."

Izuku leaned into him. Katsuki curled an arm around his waist and he rested his head against Katsuki's shoulder.

"Same for you," Izuku whispered.

They stayed like that for a while, swaying with the ship's gentle tilt.

The world beyond was dark and endless, but somehow, Izuku could feel a light inside of him returning. It was small, flickering, and fighting to be alive. And it was brought back from the brink of death by the hands of Katsuma and Katsuki. Truly, he had never imagined he could finally have the loving family he always daydreamed of.

But with Katsuma and Katsuki now both at his side, it all felt impossibly in reach.

Maybe this was what fate had meant for him all along.



The days onboard blurred together in a mix of colors.

Blue from the sky melted with the pale orange of the sunset. The yellow sun blended with the silver moon. And pretty scarlet eyes mixed together with big, brown ones as Katsuki and Katsuma became the whole of Izuku's life.

As the days went on, Izuku no longer kept time by hours or minutes. Instead, he did so in the subtle changes in Katsuma's laughter, in Katsuki's smirk, and in the way his own chest began to feel a little less heavy each morning.

At first, he struggled.

Through the weeks on board, his sleep came slow and dreamless. He was still haunted by the shadow of Tomura, and how even in death he managed to still impact their lives. The murder of Katsuma's family made guilt spread inside of him. His meals felt tasteless. And some days he didn't feel like he deserved to be in Katsuma's life.

But then an unexpected shift began.

It was small and started with laughter.

Katsuma had hidden behind one of the storage trunks in their room. He crouched low, tiny shoulders shaking as he tried to stifle giggles. Izuku had been reading at the desk when Katsuki walked in, toweling his hair dry from a shower.

The moment Katsuma leapt out with a fierce “Rawr!” Katsuki stumbled back like he’d been hit.

He slapped his hand over his heart, eyes wide with mock terror.

“Argh!” He gasped, staggering dramatically into the wall. “You got me! I’m dead—”

Katsuma burst into uncontrollable laughter. “I got you, monster!”

He giggled loudly and clapped his hands. Then suddenly, Katsuki dropped the act and smirked mischievously. Katsuma tried to run, but couldn’t flee when Katsuki scooped him up and tossed him over his shoulder.

“Now I got you!” Katsuki playfully yelled.

Izuku watched the whole thing from the desk, smiling uncontrollably. He laughed as Katsuma squealed and kicked. Then laughed some more when Katsuma got free and began running around their room. Katsuki chased after him with exaggerated roars and fake growls.

The weeks filled with moments like that.

Izuku wished he could record them all.

Another moment he loved occurred a couple days later. On the upper deck under the light of dawn, Katsuma rode high on Katsuki’s shoulders. His little hands gripped Katsuki’s hair for balance as he pointed towards the mess hall.

“Onward, Kacchan!” Katsuma shouted. “I’m hungry!”

Katsuki chuckled. “Aye aye, Captain Katsuma.”

He stomped dramatically across the deck while Izuku followed a few steps behind.

Izuku couldn’t help but grin. The sight was so sweet he was positive he gained a couple cavities from it.

As another week came and went, Katsuma’s favorite pastime quickly became playing with them in the hallways. And truthfully, it became Izuku’s too.

The three of them would wander the corridors together hand in hand. Katsuma skipped between them, his small hands in theirs and his feet tapping on the floor. Every few steps, Izuku and Katsuki would lift him high into the air. Katsuma would shriek with laughter, kicking his feet as though he could fly.

“Higher!” He would giggle.

And Izuku and Katsuki would happily comply.

Then sometimes, after putting Katsuma to bed, Izuku found himself leaning against the railing on their balcony. He would observe the boundless horizon fade into dark. The air

smelled of salt and freedom. And Izuku felt the ache in his chest ease. It didn't disappear, but the hold it had on him loosened like shackles finally being unchained.

And for once, the world seemed so simple.

ᔓᔓᔓ

Izuku watched as Nana typed leisurely on her laptop.

She hummed occasionally as she inputted various numbers and ran impressive logistics. They sat across from each other in her office. Off to the side were several computers, printers, and scanners that were stacked with manilla envelopes of various forged documents.

Katsuki stretched in the chair beside him. He yawned slightly and the yawn passed to Izuku.

They had been in here for a couple of hours while Katsuma was down for the night. Nana was wide awake with black coffee steaming at her side. She didn't pause for one second, continuously typing, writing, and stamping official documents for them. The sharp scratch of her pen occasionally was punctuated by the creak of the ship.

Nana beamed as she inputted one last thing on her laptop.

"There," she said excitedly. "All the money in your bank accounts have been discreetly drained and transferred to new ones."

"Ah, thank you so much," Izuku replied. He smiled with profound gratefulness. "You have no idea how much we appreciate all this."

"You can thank me later," she joked, leaning back in her large chair. "With this much money, you two will be set for life. Honestly, you don't ever have to work again if you don't want to."

Katsuki waved a dismissive hand. "I'm too much of a workaholic for that."

"I can see that," Nana replied, amused. "But it's something to keep in mind." She leaned forward and looked at her notepad. She tapped her pen a couple of times and then flipped to the next page. "So. Our next stops are as follows: we'll be making a port in South Korea first, then Taiwan, then the Philippines, and finally, Singapore."

Katsuki's brow lifted. "Singapore is our new location?"

"Yup," Nana said, grinning. "Yakuza don't usually cross into Singapore. Luckily for you, it's the territory of the Ghee Hin Kongsi. They've been enemies of the Yakuza for decades. Tons of bad blood and old grudges. The Chisakis wouldn't dare risk it."

A foreign calm settled in Izuku's chest.

They were going to be safe. It felt inconceivable, but hearing it in Nana's voice made it sound possible.

“Do either of you speak English, Mandarin, or Malay?” she asked, glancing between them.

“I suck at languages,” Katsuki admitted. “But I know enough English to get by. Luckily, Izuku’s a polyglot. He can bail me out until I improve.”

“Oh, really?” Nana’s brows rose, impressed. “How many languages do you know?”

“I know most spoken across Asia and Europe,” Izuku admitted, modestly. “I can teach Katsuki easily enough.” He turned to his fiancé with a teasing glint in his eye. “I guess your bad Mandarin is finally getting an upgrade.”

Katsuki smirked. “Oh, I bet your nerdy ass will *love* teaching me, huh?”

“Perfect match,” Nana said, laughing as she clicked over to the final tab on her laptop. “Now then—last thing on the checklist: your new identities and backstories. I already have worked something out that I think you’ll both adapt to pretty well.”

“What did you have in mind?” Katsuki asked.

“I’ve set you up as a married couple,” she explained. “You two are Japanese expats who’ve been living in China for a while. As a couple, you have decided to move to Singapore for a slower life. Katsuma’s legally your little brother now, Izuku. You adopted him after your parents were killed in a car crash when he was a baby.”

Izuku’s eyes dropped at how close to the truth that was.

Nana continued, “Katsuki, you’ll come from a long line of old wealth. Your family made their fortune generations ago and all tragically died in a fire. You inherited everything young.”

Katsuki raised an eyebrow. “That’s pretty dramatic, don’t you think?”

“People love drama,” Nana said simply. “But the main story is, you two are starting over after losing your families. No one looks twice at people who say that they’ve loved and lost.”

Izuku nodded, accepting the story without question. She was right, that would be easy for both of them to play along with, especially after everything they had lost. Acting like they were two orphans who found love was as close to the truth as they would get.

Katsuki nodded too. “Just to make sure the story is air tight, what kind of company did my family run?”

Nana shrugged. “Up to you. Pick something that you like.”

Katsuki went quiet for a while, fingers drumming against the arm of his chair.

Then he said, “I like the idea that my family made their fortune on classical music. Maybe we were a family of instrument makers and composers. My background could be in composition or something. We could say I met Izuku while selling him a violin, and we bonded over it.”

“I like that,” Izuku said, smiling. “That’s actually really nice, Kacchan.”

Nana chuckled as she typed. “That’s the sweetest backstory I’ve written all year.”

When she finished entering it, she leaned back again and said, “Now how about you, Izuku? What would you like your backstory to be?”

Izuku had to think about it.

He always made comments about past and future lives, but really never truly indulged himself. But as he thought about it, he envisioned what life would have been like if he and Katsuki ran away the first time. And right when he did, he could perfectly see what they could’ve been.

“I want to have a background in literature and violin,” Izuku said dreamily. “I got an education in reading romantic novels, did my thesis on them and I professionally played violin as well on the side.”

Katsuki’s hand squeezed him lovingly, showing approval.

“Lovely,” Nana commented. “And last but not least, all that’s left is your government identities. Do you want to change your first names, your surnames, or both?”

Izuku would be happy to relieve himself of his whole identity if needed. He was ready to say ‘both’ but paused when he glanced at Katsuki. There was the smallest crack in his fiancé’s expression. His mouth was pressed together and the frown on his face was deeper than normal.

“We can keep Bakugou,” Izuku said. “Let’s only change our first names.”

Katsuki turned his head. His eyes were slightly bigger, but Izuku could see the relief inside of them.

“Are you sure?” Katsuki questioned. He treaded lightly and leaned in. “I don’t mind losing Bakugou if you think another last name would be better.”

Izuku shook his head. “I think Bakugou suits you. It suits *us*.”

Katsuki smiled affectionately.

Nana nodded at them, smiling as well. “Bakugou it is. What do you two have in mind for first names? Let’s start with Katsuma’s.”

Izuku knew this one easily. “His favorite superhero is named Kenji. I used to secretly read him those comics when he was little. He’d be happy to be called that any day.”

Nana laughed, deep from her stomach. “Ah, yes! I had to read him a lot of those comics the last few months too. Bakugou Kenji has a nice ring to it. Now, what about you two?”

Katsuki hummed, thoughtful. “Y’know. I never really thought another name could suit me.”

They both tried to brainstorm. Izuku scanned his memory for any sort of name that would fit, and maybe represent how far they've come. And then—instantly, Izuku knew. The idea came to him in a spark, lighting through his chest.

He turned to Katsuki with wide eyes and an even wider grin.

"I think I know what names we should choose," he said, mischief glinting in his eyes.

Katsuki looked at him, confused. "Yeah? What do you have in mind?"

ᔓᔓᔓ

Nana slid the finished documents across the desk.

"All set," she said happily. "Meet your new lives."

Katsuki picked his passport up first, flipping it open with a skeptical snort.

"You're really lucky you're cute," he muttered, shooting Izuku a playful glance. "Otherwise I would've said *fuck no* to this."

Izuku laughed cheerfully. "I think it fits perfectly."

"Yeah, you're right," Katsuki snickered.

The two of them leaned together over the new passports. The scent of ink lingered between them as they looked at them together. Their faces stared back at them. Same eyes, same mouths, and same hair. But now, they were framed with different names, ready to start anew.

Izuku traced the letters with his thumb.

Bakugou Taro and Bakugou Hiroji.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you so much for reading!! Please let me know what you think below!! <3

Chapter 52: Reprise

Chapter Summary

> Reprise (Definition) — A reiteration of an opening material later in a musical composition.

Chapter Notes

> Helloooo everyone :)) Welcome back to this choo choo train of LOVEEEE!! 💕 We're in the final chapters and its so bitter sweet 🥹 this chapter was very healing to write and really made me smile the whole time. I hope you enjoy!! Big thank you to the love of my life, Luna for Betaing like always!!
>
> **Warnings: Adult scenes and themes**

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 52 — Reprise

.

.

.

“Arms up,” Izuku said.

Katsuma obeyed. But as he did, his eyes drifted to the corner where his coat hung on a hook. Izuku made a move to put the tiny shirt over the boy’s head. But a moment later, Katsuma made a determined walk towards his coat. Izuku laughed softly and scooped him up before he could reach it.

“No coat needed today,” Izuku said with a smile. “It’s going to be warm where we’re going.”

Katsuma frowned, doubtful. “Are you sure?”

From across the room, Katsuki grunted. “He’s telling the truth, buddy. It’s going to be stupidly hot, like we’re walking on the sun. Be prepared to melt.”

Katsuma gasped in horror.

Izuku shot Katsuki a glare over his shoulder. “Don’t scare him.”

Katsuki shrugged, closing one bag’s zipper with a quick snap. “I’m only preparing him.”

Izuku was going to reprimand his fiancé, but he snickered instead. It was terribly difficult to be mad today. Maybe because it was the start of a new era. He could feel the burning excitement teeming beneath his skin.

Nana had informed them the previous night that they were finally docking in Singapore. After endless weeks at sea, it felt like a miracle. She had completed her excursion, stopping at discreet ports across Asia, scattering people into new lives. Some of those individuals they had grown to know. They were kind and also looking for nothing but peace. When they all parted ways, everyone wished each other nothing but the best.

And now, it was their turn.

Throughout the room, half-folded clothes stacked in uneven piles, and bags were yawning open on the beds. Katsuki hunched over the desk, muttering under his breath as he tried to commit all the details of their forged lives. And somewhere in the chaos, Izuku crouched in front of Katsuma. He finished coaxing him into the tiny button-down shirt and pants they’d picked out the night before.

Packing went quickly after that. Izuku smoothed out Katsuma’s collar. Katsuki double-checked every pocket of every bag. And outside their door, Nana called out reminders in the hallways like a general marshaling her troops.

And then, almost too quickly, the moment arrived.

Nana knocked on their door.

“Bakugous,” she called. “It’s time. Get prepared to head out in about fifteen minutes.”

Izuku nervously pressed his hand to his stomach. His heart was beating fast as he grabbed a couple of their bags and strapped Katsuma’s little red backpack to his body. They headed for the deck, arms chuck full of their belongings.

And when they arrived at the top, the air hit hard. It was thick, warm, and impossibly humid. In the sky above, the dawn was only beginning to break. A soft, molten yellow reached across the horizon and painted the sea in golden fragments.

Izuku stopped in his tracks, letting the view settle around him.

Beside him, Katsuki muttered, “Wow,” quietly. Katsuma squinted into the light, burying his face briefly against Izuku’s leg. Nana stood in front of them, hands on her hips. Her whole figure slowly became silhouetted against the rising sun. She glanced back with a wry smile.

“You won’t ever have to worry about winter again,” Nana joked.

Katsuki dryly scoffed. “Good. I’ve had enough snow to last five lifetimes.”

The cicadas were the first to greet them. Their buzzing was a steady chorus in Izuku's ears as they all stood before a house. Inside his chest, his heart beat just as loudly. It thudded frantically against his ribs as he stared at the blue door. Behind it, the house rose gracefully. Broad-leafed mahogany trees and infinite greenery framed their new home.

Izuku took in every detail that he could. The color was crisp white, and the edges were softened by climbing foliage. It stood about three stories tall directly next to the bright blue sea. Overall, it wasn't extravagant or too large.

But it was just the right size for a small circle of people who cared for each other.

"This is *beautiful*," Katsuki whispered in awe. "How did you pick this out?"

"Aizawa gave me some hints," Nana said. "He told me you wanted a quiet retirement in the countryside. And he suggested that you all might enjoy a warmer climate."

"He was right," Katsuki laughed, still in shock. He glanced around, eyes catching on a mango tree off to the side. "Thank you so much, Nana. I don't know how many more times I can thank you, but—I'm just so grateful."

"You may have to say thank you one more time," she teased. "You haven't even seen the backyard yet. It's big enough for a certain little boy to play around in until he's nice and sleepy."

Katsuma peered from behind Izuku's leg. "There's a backyard?"

Nana smiled at him. "Mhm. Wait until you see it. You're going to love it."

She reached into her pocket and withdrew a golden key. Katsuma smiled brightly as she stepped forward and slid it into the lock. And with a gentle click, the door eased open as if it'd been awaiting them.

"Welcome to your new beginning," Nana said, her smile widening with pride.

When they stepped inside, Izuku felt the world tilt. It shifted from teetering on danger to finally exhaling. He leaned all the way into that shift and let his shoulders creep down from his ears.

"Tour time!" Nana said with glee.

She led them inside, walking through the living room first. It was a cozy space with warm light pooling across polished floors. All around were built-in shelves waiting to be filled with books, and a wide window looked over the distant green hills through the backyard.

Izuku could already imagine mornings here. He could perfectly picture Katsuma sprawled on the rug playing with his toys and Katsuki getting ready for work on the couch smiling at him.

The kitchen was next. It was full of windows, allowing endless natural light inside. They had ample counter room in the spacious area to cook food. Izuku knew Katsuki was going to love that. And complimenting the counters, sharp stainless steel lined everything, with brand new pots and pans hanging up along the walls.

“Whoa,” Katsuki muttered, eyes widening despite himself. “This is a nice setup.”

They continued through the house. Nana showed them the backyard with the pond, and the mango trees that had fruit waiting to be picked. She showed them the long hallways that were lined with various rooms. A study. A private office. Then, when they went to the second floor, Nana opened another door. It was obvious who it was for.

Katsuma squealed with excitement.

“And this, of course, is his room,” Nana chuckled.

The boy stepped inside, eyes sparkling as he took it all in. They all admired the small bed, the soft orange walls, and the trunk of toys underneath the large window. Izuku walked over to a tiny book shelf and squatted low. He blinked back tears when he saw what was there. It was all stories that taught about love, family, and encouraged kindness.

“I figured out some stuff he might like,” Nana said quietly as Katsuma jumped on to the bed.

“You did great,” Izuku whispered.

Next, Nana opened a second door across the hall. It was a playroom stuffed with endless educational tools. There was a drawing board, and a small desk for Katsuma to do his future schooling.

Finally, they reached the top floor, and the last door.

The primary bedroom opened wide before them. It had tall windows and a gentleness about it. Izuku lingered on the threshold, overwhelmed by the promise of it. Inside wasn’t much, just a single king sized bed and a dresser.

“I decided to go light on the furnishing, so you can decorate how you want,” Nana explained. “It’s a blank canvas.”

They walked in further, and that’s when Izuku realized the large windows were actually doors. Nana pushed them open, and revealed a large, breathtaking balcony overlooking the water. Katsuki breathed in the fresh air, and Izuku smiled softened as the breeze blew through his hair.

They stepped out together with Katsuma tucked safely between them. And the world opened before them in a sweeping, breathtaking expanse. The countryside rolled into green hills and waving palms. Then beside it, the impossibly blue water shimmered under the sun.

Katsuma grabbed the railing with both hands. His eyes were wide and shining as he gasped at the sight.

“So,” Nana laughed, watching them with a tender gaze. “What do you think?”

They both glanced at her over his shoulder, grinning from ear to ear.

“It’s perfect,” Katsuki said.

ᔓᔓᔓ

The late morning light slanted through the palm leaves as Nana led them down the tranquil roads of their new neighborhood.

As they walked, Izuku noted the houses weren’t too terribly far apart. He could see their new neighbors walking and chatting with grins on their faces. He smiled at how peaceful their new town was. It had wide sidewalks and bursts of bougainvillea curling over fences.

“And this,” Nana said, gesturing ahead, “is the closest grocery store. You guys can get fresh produce every day here. It’s locally grown, and has some of the best fruit I’ve ever tasted.”

Katsuma darted ahead to peer through the glass doors. He pressed his face against the cool surface before Izuku gently pulled him back with a laugh. They continued on, passing cafes, small clinics, and a quiet park dotted with shade from trees. Inside, families lounged on benches with coffees in their hands and smiles on their lips.

Nana walked them up a small hill to a bright building with floral painted murals along the sides.

“And here,” she said, resting her hand on Katsuma’s shoulder, “is your new school, Katsuma! You’re already enrolled for next year.” She smiled at Izuku. “The teachers are good people. They’re all super patient and attentive. I think by the time fall semester comes, he’ll be adjusted enough to do great.”

Katsuma looked up at Nana with a shy grin and clutched Izuku’s hand. Izuku swallowed around the sudden rush of emotion at the sight. Who knew that seeing a kindergarten would make him feel so hopeful?

Katsuma was really going to have a normal childhood.

A montage unfolded in warm, sunlit pieces as Nana pointed out bus routes, shortcut paths, and a corner store that sold surprisingly good breakfast buns. As they strolled, Katsuki lifted Katsuma onto his shoulders so he could see the water again.

Eventually, they found themselves back at the edge of their property during sunset.

Nana turned to them with a bittersweet smile. She gazed at each one of them, taking her time. A small shimmer appeared in her eyes, and a protective love blossomed across her face. She quietly clasped her hands together.

“This is where I leave you,” she said sadly. “I’m so happy you both found me. And I’m honored to give you the opportunity to start fresh. I want you to know as well, your death

certificates in Japan have been filed on public record. Your past lives are formally dead and buried."

"Thank you so much, Nana," Katsuki said, bowing slightly. "If you ever need anything, please let us know. We'd be more than happy to help you."

"The only thing I want you two to do is relax," she joked. Nana then kneeled down to Katsuma's level and held her arms out with a sweet smile. "I have to go now, Katsuma. Give me a hug."

Izuku had never seen Katsuma run towards someone so readily before. He threw himself into Nana's arms with a big hug and squeezed her tightly.

"Will you come back to visit?" He asked in a tiny voice.

Nana stroked his head and nodded. "I'll come back as soon as I can. But you have to make sure you are a good boy for your brother, okay? Don't give him much trouble and remember to give him a lot of hugs."

"I will!" Katsuma said brightly.

They pulled apart, and Izuku had to wipe a tear from the corner of his eye. "Thank you again."

"Of course," she said. "But it's not goodbye. I'll be in and out, checking in on you. I've, uh, taken a bit of a special interest in making sure you two turn out alright. So it's goodbye for now, but not forever."

"I like the sound of that," Katsuki said with a grin.

When Nana stood up, she pulled a small, sleek phone out of her pocket.

"And one last thing," she said, pressing the device into Katsuki's hand. "This is an emergency contact line. In case anything, and I mean *anything*, goes wrong or seems suspicious, please use this. It's encrypted and preloaded with two numbers—mine, and someone else who vigorously insisted."

Katsuki powered it on.

The screen lit up, revealing exactly two contacts.

Shimura Nana.

And—Shouta Aizawa.

Both Katsuki and Izuku froze for a moment.

Then, identical, helpless smiles broke across their faces.

After Nana departed, they all stood together in the empty living room. The silence stretched wide around them as they took in the new space. Katsuma wandered a few steps in. He kept his small hands clasped behind his back as he peered around shyly. He lifted his eyes to Izuku, enormous but uncertain.

“All this is ours?” he asked softly.

“It is,” Izuku replied warmly.

“Really?” Katsuma pressed, as though afraid the house might vanish if he blinked. He bashfully tilted his head. “Will we…see our other brothers and sisters? Are they coming too?” He paused. “Is…is Big Brother Tomura coming?”

The fear in his voice was microscopic, but it cut straight through the atmosphere.

“No,” Izuku answered solidly.

He ignored the complex sadness tugging at his chest. Wearily, he glanced at their bags in the hallway. Even though he couldn’t see it, he could feel the presence of the urn inside the luggage.

Delicately, Izuku knelt down. He placed both hands on Katsuma’s small shoulders.

“Tomura won’t be around ever again,” Izuku explained pensively.

Katsuma absorbed that, brows knitting. “So…that means you’re not going to get hurt anymore?”

Izuku’s breathing stopped—and so did Katsuki’s. Both their eyes widened, and Izuku’s heart twisted horribly.

“I—” He swallowed hard and blinked rapidly, forcing down the lump in his throat. “I’m not. You won’t ever have to see me get hurt again. And we have Kacchan to thank for that.”

Katsuma’s face lit up with pure relief. And before Izuku could brace for it, tiny arms wrapped around his neck.

“Does this mean Kacchan is going to stay with us?” Katsuma asked into his shoulder. “He’ll make sure you don’t get hurt anymore?”

A fragile laugh broke out from Izuku. He hugged Katsuma closer.

“Yeah,” he whispered. “He’s staying with us from now on.”

Izuku lifted his head, turning toward Katsuki with shining eyes. Katsuki stepped closer, unable to look away.

“Thank you, Kacchan!” Katsuma chirped as he finally pulled back.

“It’s no problem, buddy,” Katsuki replied quietly.

He crouched down beside them. His smile was small but impossibly gentle. Izuku met his gaze, and the room went entirely still. The sound of the birds faded, the ocean calmed and the sun fully set.

The only thing left was a private exchange between them.



The countryside stilled as the sky shifted from rose-gold to deep violet. They spent the hours wandering through their new home and its surroundings, simply enjoying the calm. Katsuma chased fireflies in the backyard while Katsuki joined him after finding a jar. Izuku laughed as he watched them collect the insects, both their faces illuminated by the yellow light.

Eventually, the three of them were eating a simple dinner on the floor of their empty living room with their legs stretched out. They talked about decor, and the infinite possibilities made all of their hearts full.

As night settled, the house grew dimmer but warmer.

An unfamiliar harmony draped itself around them. It was thin at first, fragile as spun glass, but Izuku held on tightly. And when Katsuma made his first yawn of the evening, they knew it was time for this surreal day to come to a close. They guided the young boy up the stairs to his new room.

“Do I have to go to school tomorrow?” Katsuma asked, climbing up onto the mattress and sitting cross-legged. “Nana said I would go to a nice people school. No more training involved.”

Izuku smiled, smoothing a wrinkle in the comforter.

“She’s right but you’re not starting just yet,” he explained. “You’re going to start next fall. But in the meantime, we’re going to get to spend time together—fully uninterrupted. I won’t be going anywhere for a long time.”

Katsuma’s shoulders eased, and a small smile formed. “Really?”

“Yup! And when you do start school,” Izuku continued, brushing a hand through Katsuma’s hair. “You’ll start kindergarten with other kids your age, and they’re going to be so kind to you.”

Katsuma’s face lit up. “You’re not lying?”

“Not at all. You’re going to make so many new, kind hearted friends.”

Izuku pulled the blanket up to Katsuma’s chin, tucking him in snugly. Katsuma immediately wrapped his arms around Izuku’s neck, yanking him down into another tight hug. Izuku closed his eyes, holding Katsuma longer than necessary. When he finally pulled back, Katsuma stared up at Katsuki expectantly.

"…I want a hug from Kacchan too."

Katsuki blinked, startled. "Me?"

Katsuma nodded, stubborn and earnest.

Izuku burst into a loud laugh and used his hand to cover his mouth. Katsuki scratched behind his head but still stepped forward. He leaned down awkwardly, arms going around Katsuma in a stiff but sincere embrace.

Katsuma giggled brightly and delightedly. Izuku laughed harder, eyes crinkling.

Katsuki pulled back, cheeks a little warm. "Alright, alright. Go to sleep, gremlin."

"Night, 'Zuku!" Katsuma chimed. "And goodnight, Kacchan!"

They said their goodbyes and switched off the lights. Izuku's heart grew tepid as he watched Katsuma snuggle into his pillow, already drifting away.

Soundlessly, they closed the door behind them and walked down the hall.

As they strolled, a bubble of happiness built inside Izuku. It grew with every step, taking up more room as his smile inched bigger and bigger. He shyly brushed Katsuki's hand, and his lover mirthfully nudged his shoulder.

He stole a glance at Katsuki and was delighted to see he wasn't alone in his joy. The other man had the same barely contained giddy expression. They made their way into their new bedroom, and the second the door closed—they broke out into boyish grins of sheer exuberance.

It was impossible to tell who kissed whom first.

Their lips met in a clumsy, laughing collision. Then suddenly, it was a cascade of tiny pecks. Katsuki kissed Izuku's nose, his eyelids, and his cheeks. He cupped Izuku's face with both hands while Izuku smiled so hard his jaw hurt.

"We did it," Katsuki said, forehead pressed to his. "Holy *shit*, we actually did it. Izuku. We made it out."

Izuku laughed, breathless. "We did!"

"And we're finally married again," Katsuki added, grinning so wide it bordered on feral. He kissed the corner of Izuku's mouth. "But I'm going to marry you properly one day—I mean it. Our wedding is going to be *exactly* how you always dreamed, and I'll be damned if it goes any other way."

Izuku felt his heart soar. "I can't wait for that day too. I'm so happy to call you my husband again."

They kissed once more, and Izuku could only describe the feeling as elation.

It was as if there were a cloud of a hundred butterflies under his feet. He floated in pure joy as they shared their joint bliss. As Izuku soared higher, the kiss intensified. The butterflies carried him away as they stumbled back, gripping each other in disbelief.

Izuku gasped lightly as the back of his knees hit the edge of the new bed. They went tumbling, and the sound of laughter came with their fall. They bounced on the mattress, smiling like fools against each other's lips.

Another burst of joy erupted in him, and Izuku threw his head back. His wild curls splayed across the white linen sheets. He laughed, unrestrained.

"I can't believe it," Izuku exclaimed. "I really can't believe it. Kacchan, we get a new life."

"It was always in the cards for us," Katsuki muttered against his lips. "It's fate or whatever the hell it's called."

His words wrapped around Izuku's heart, squeezing tight. Izuku's smile softened as Katsuki lifted his head. Otherworldly, devoted scarlet eyes locked onto him, and Izuku's heart skipped a beat. Their expressions mirrored the other, echoing years of strife and love.

Katsuki leaned in, breath ghosting against Izuku's lips.

"Y'know, I think we've shared more beds than I can keep track of now," he said mischievously. He bit his lip and raised a brow. "But it's something about knowing this one is for our new life together that makes me eager to break it in. What do you say, Mr. Bakugou?"

Izuku chuckled. "I say that sounds amazing, Mr. Bakugou."

Katsuki grinned brilliantly right before he captured Izuku's mouth.

Instantly, their lips fused with a fervency that felt both inexorable and exquisitely familiar. Those warm, time-worn hands curved around his body, drawing him into an embrace that was as anchoring as it was consuming. Izuku surrendered to it fully. He fell, impossibly deeper into the well of love he held for his husband.

Wow. He missed being able to say that.

His *husband*.

The kiss ignited like an ember blooming from tinder, and warmth spread across every inch of his skin. Izuku's hands roamed up Katsuki's sides, bunching up the fabric of his shirt as he arched upwards. The heat from their bodies melted together, making him feel safe and loved.

Katsuki's mouth moved with more purpose now. He sucked on Izuku's lower lip before he slid his tongue inside. Izuku moaned softly, the sound swallowed entirely as Katsuki's weight settled more firmly on him.

Izuku pushed his tongue against his husband's, chasing the warmth that spread from his core. It spilled across his body as his husband gave a slow grind. The fervor filled his veins and

sent shutters down his spine. Izuku gasped as his own cock grew hard, straining against Katsuki's.

He broke away from the kiss and glanced up.

Heated stares had replaced their smiles, and electricity sparked in the air. Izuku ground up, chasing the friction that bloomed low in his belly. Katsuki's response was instant. He gripped Izuku tighter and slowly left a trail of open mouth kisses along his jaw.

"You're mine now, Izuku," he hoarsely whispered.

"And you're all mine too."

Katsuki nodded as his fingers dipped under Izuku's shirt. He pushed the fabric up slowly, and the cool air from the room caressed Izuku's skin. But Katsuki's touch chased it away. Calloused palms dragged up his sides with delicate, mindful care. His husband gripped his shirt and slowly peeled it away. Then soon, away went his pants, his socks, and his underwear.

He laid underneath Katsuki, fully on display.

Gorgeous scarlet eyes roamed his body, and Izuku felt his cock twitch. Heat rushed down between his legs as Katsuki's hands roamed everywhere, teasing and ghosting tiny trails of worship. When his husband kissed his neck, Izuku couldn't think of anyone else he'd ever want to be with like this.

He reached forward then and hooked his fingers under Katsuki's shirt. He did the same and stripped Katsuki bare and rid him of all his clothes. His husband's cock hung free, hard and already leaking for him as his taut muscles flexed under the dim moonlight.

Izuku pressed his hand flat against Katsuki's chest and then firmly flipped them.

He confidently straddled his husband's hips and seated himself directly on top.

Surprised but delighted, Katsuki smirked at him. "You wanna ride tonight?"

"Yeah." Izuku grinned while pink crept up his ears. "I've missed feeling you inside me…you have no clue."

Katsuki shifted onto his elbows. "I got some lube in my bag. I grabbed it during a pit stop on our way down to Okinawa."

"…It's funny you say that."

Katsuki raised a brow. "What do you mean?"

Izuku's heart pounded with excitement as he reached for his own bag that sat at the side of the bed. He dipped his hand into the small pocket and pulled out a tiny pink bottle of lube. He brought it up to view, showing his husband with a mirthful grin.

“Now when did you get that?” Katsuki teased.

“I *may* have also bought some during a pit stop?” Izuku admitted with a cheesy grin. “I guess we had the same thought.”

Katsuki barked a sharp laugh and rested a hand comfortably on Izuku’s hip. “Well, look at us —great minds really do think alike.”

Izuku smiled at him as he popped the cap. He squeezed a generous amount onto his fingers and let the slick gel warm against his skin. He massaged it between his fingertips slowly as he sat back. His husband’s cock slotted perfectly between his bare cheeks, pressing hard against all his sensitive areas.

Izuku leaned forward slightly, balancing on his knees. He brought his lubed fingers to his entrance carefully. He circled the tight ring of muscle first, coating it thoroughly, then pushed one finger inside himself.

The initial stretch burned just right, sending a shiver up his spine. He softly moaned as he worked it in and out slowly, building the rhythm. His free hand braced on top of Katsuki’s chest for support. The sensation made his own cock throb, bringing it fully erect and leaking pre-cum onto Katsuki’s abs.

His husband’s intense eyes locked onto the sight, dark and hungry. Gradually, his breathing shifted. Katsuki’s breath began to come out in shallow huffs, as he rested his hands on Izuku’s hips. He was mesmerized, thumbs rubbing soothing circles into the skin.

“Darling,” he murmured, voice full of arousal. “Look at you, opening up yourself for me like that. Does it feel good?”

Izuku nodded. “I-It does.”

Katsuki’s pupils dilated in hunger. “Can you make yourself whimper for me?”

Emboldened, Izuku added a second finger. He scissored them to stretch himself wider then angled them just right. His breath hitched low in his throat as he pressed against his prostate. Electric sparks flooded his senses.

Izuku’s eyes fluttered close as he did it again. Then once more. He set a small, addictive rhythm as he happily pleasured himself. Ecstasy coiled tight in his gut as his hips rocked instinctively, chasing the sensation. Then soon, Izuku’s breathing quickened.

He lost himself in the moment, unaware of the way Katsuki was cursing quietly.

He also then missed his husband reaching for the lube and slicking one of his own fingers down.

Izuku’s eyes snapped open when he felt an extra nudge alongside his fingers. He groaned deeply at the added stretch. His body clenched down around the intrusion, but welcomed it greedily.

Together, they moved. Katsuki's finger thrusted in sync with Izuku's, twisting and probing. He filled Izuku deeper as their breaths began to match in pace.

The dual pressure had Izuku moaning openly, his voice breaking as waves of heat pulsed through him.

He ached as the pace built and he was filled up with a second finger of Katsuki's. He shuttered, overcome with pleasure as he dropped forward. His head pushed into the crook of Katsuki's neck, lips pressing against the warm skin there as groans spilled from him.

Sweat beaded on his muscular back as the moonlight cast shadows over their joined bodies. With Katsuki participating in the effort, the slick sounds overcame the quiet room. Pleasure built relentlessly, and his cock twitched with every caress against his prostate.

Katsuki turned his head, lips brushing Izuku's temple in a soft kiss.

"*Darling*," Katsuki called to him in his deepest octave. "I don't think I ever told you—after you passed out in that shitty motel, you were dripping so much goddamn cum."

Izuku shivered as Katsuki pushed inside deeper. "Ye-Yeah?"

"Mhm," Katsuki hissed. He fucked his fingers in harder, making Izuku moan a little louder. "God. Darling, it was so goddamn hot. I never told you I licked you clean that night with my tongue. I ate all the cum right out of you."

Izuku's hazy eyes opened, dilated all the way. "Kacchan, you did that?"

"Damn right I did. And you were whimpering the whole time. *Fuck*. You should've heard yourself. I had to make sure I tongued you down *very* gently too."

A deep groan rumbled from the back of Izuku's throat as he pushed his hips onto the fingers harder.

Katsuki bit his lip. "You like that image, don't you?"

Izuku nodded feverishly with the base of his neck burned red. "I do. I *really* like that image."

Finally, when his legs were trembling just right, Izuku pulled his fingers free with a wet pop. Katsuki followed suit, leaving Izuku stretched and ready.

Izuku panted against Katsuki's neck, lifting his head to meet those scarlet eyes.

"Now to get you slicked up," Izuku whispered huskily.

Katsuki nodded, his cock standing rigid against his abs. It was fully veined with tip glistening, waiting for him. The sight alone made Izuku's mouth water, and cock jump. He shifted up and backwards and grabbed the base with one hand.

Without breaking eye contact with his husband, he began to stroke it. He poured lube all over the veiny cock, double fisting it to make sure every inch of it was nice and wet. He teased a

little too. His thumb slid through the pre-cum slick slit, drawing a throaty groan from his husband that he loved.

And right when Katsuki seemed ready to burst, Izuku lined himself up.

He sank down slowly, the blunt head breaching him. It stretched his rim around its girth, and a sharp moan escaped him as he took the first few inches. He bit his trembling lip as the burn morphed into exquisite fullness. Inch by inch, he lowered himself. His walls clenched and fluttered around the throbbing cock until he was fully seated, filled up to the brim.

“Fuck, *finally*,” Katsuki growled in a low rumble that vibrated through Izuku’s core. “You feel so damn good.”

His hands clamped down on Izuku’s hips, fingers digging deep into the soft flesh. He held Izuku in place as if he might float away from the intensity. Katsuki closed his eyes and tipped his head back against the pillow, beautiful blond hair spilling across the cloth.

Izuku’s breath caught at the lovely sight, and his body thrummed with insatiable need.

He braced his palms flat against Katsuki’s broad chest, drinking in the rapid thud of his husband’s heartbeat under his sweat-slicked skin. The muscles there flexed under his touch, grounding him as he lifted his hips.

Katsuki’s thick cock slid almost all the way out, dragging against his inner walls. Carefully, Izuku teased his own rim with the flared head before slamming back down. The sudden fullness punched a gasp from his lungs, and his ass clenched around the base.

They both moaned at the sensation, eyes seeped in desire. Fully in sync, both their toes curled, and Izuku set a rhythm.

He began rising and falling, each descent forcing Katsuki’s cock deeper inside of him. He moaned lewdly as the tip nudged insistently against his prostate. Scorching sparks shot up his spine like electric jolts, making his vision blur at the edges. His own cock slapped against Katsuki’s skin with every bounce, leaving trails of pre-cum that glistened in the moonlight.

The wet clap of skin on skin echoed in the room. The sound mingled with their ragged breaths and the creak of the bed beneath them.

Suddenly, confidence he never felt bloomed in his chest. It was fierce, and pure as he picked up speed.

His hips rolled more fluidly now, grinding down to a circle. He clenched as he came up, milking a groan and shudder out of his husband. Izuku savored the way his lover’s perfect cock filled every inch of him.

Sweat dripped down from his nape, trailing down his back. He picked up the pace, pleasing himself fully unabashed. He angled himself just right, making Katsuki’s girthy tip hit dead on against his pleasure spot. With an enticing moan, Izuku tossed his head back, curls sticking to his forehead.

The angle was perfect. He reached down and began stroking himself, catching his sensitive slit with every pull. Izuku's thighs burned, but he didn't care. The ache fueled him, making him ride harder and faster. He chased the release that hovered just out of reach.

Katsuki began bucking up to meet every downward plunge. He snapped his hips with measured, controlled power, driving his cock in deeper. He kept a firm grip on Izuku, guiding the motion, pulling him down harder when he faltered.

"There we go," Katsuki panted. His hazy eyes were locked on Izuku's face, drinking in every parted lip moan. Beads of sweat rolled down his temples, and his abs tightened with each thrust. "C'mon. Bounce on it harder, baby. Milk me with that tight ass of yours."

The dirty praise washed over Izuku, and his body responded with a fresh wave of heat. His walls clenched involuntarily as he leaned forward, changing the angle just enough to grind his prostate harder. He sped up, setting a new, bed quaking pace. The friction sent white-hot pleasure spinning through him. His cock throbbed painfully, leaking steadily now as the head became swollen and sensitive.

"*Kacchan*," Izuku whimpered. "F-Fuck, Kacchan, I missed your cock so much—" His voice broke as he rode with all he had.

Katsuki's hands began to roam. One slid up to pinch and toy with Izuku's nipple while the other stayed on his hip, urging him on. Izuku twitched sharply at the sudden flick at his sensitive chest, arching into a perfect bow.

He bounced harder as Katsuki rolled his erect nub between his fingers, moaning as quietly as he could. But soon, desperation wrapped tightly around all his senses. The pleasure built, tantalizing and hypnotizing as it pushed on his core. His mouth dropped as his legs went numb from the countless ripples of rapture.

"Come on, darling," Katsuki urged, his thrusts growing erratic as well. "I want to feel you cum on my cock. You're *so* close, I can tell by how your little hole is clenching me."

Those words shattered Izuku's hold on sanity, and everything crashed together.

The relentless friction. The deep thrusts. The filthy encouragement.

His moans spiked to frantic cries, body tensing like a bowstring pulled taut. Pleasure crested in a blinding rush, and his balls drew up tight. Without grace, his orgasm ripped through him.

Thick ropes of cum erupted from his twitching cock, splattering across Katsuki's chest, abs, and even the tip of his chin. Izuku's walls spasmed wildly around Katsuki's length, clamping down in rhythmic pulses that milked every inch, pulling groans from both of them.

Izuku gasped as he collapsed forward onto Katsuki's chest. He ignored the way his release smeared between their bodies, mixing with their sweat. Intense waves of ecstasy pulsed through him, leaving him trembling and boneless.

However, Katsuki's cock throbbed several times. It was still rock hard, a reminder that his husband wasn't done. Izuku's mind fogged, expecting a moment to catch his breath—

—But then Katsuki bucked upward.

He slammed his cock back into Izuku's spent hole. The sudden thrust punched a startled yelp from Izuku's throat. His overstimulated walls fluttered wildly around the invading length. The pleasure it came with bordered on pain now. It was too intense as the head of Katsuki's dick ground against his prostate with ruthless precision.

Izuku's eyes flew wide, teeth gritting hard. His vision sparked white at the edges like fireworks exploding behind his lids.

"Ka-Kacchan—" Izuku gasped, eyes nearly rolling back in pleasure.

He hadn't expected this—or maybe he should've.

Katsuki placed a kiss on his nose. "I'm gonna make your pretty ass cum so much tonight."

And that was all Izuku got before his husband gave it his all.

Izuku's moans escalated in pitch, hitting higher and higher with each drive. Katsuki planted his feet flat on the mattress and began funneling all his leg power into it. He sent jolts of electric heat ripping through Izuku and Izuku felt the grip on his composure slip away.

His body stirred with fresh twitches of arousal despite the sensitivity. And then in no time, his cock throbbed back to life, oversensitive and twitching from the friction.

Izuku's nails dug into Katsuki's chest, seeking an anchor in the storm.

However, the relentless pounding made his limbs jelly, and his mind was a bustling whirlwind of white-hot sensation.

Panting through clenched teeth, Izuku forced his eyes open, blinking away the blur. Katsuki stared back at him, scarlet eyes blazing with a feral hunger that bordered on wildness. But beneath it simmered raw, possessive love that made Izuku's heart soar. His husband's face was flushed, lips parted in a snarl, and sweat trickled down his sharp jawline.

The sight of Izuku unraveling utterly consumed him.

"I wish you could see how you look right now," Katsuki rasped, eyes darkening. "You got cum all over me, whimpering, and you're shaking like a leaf. It makes me wanna wreck you even more."

"D-do it," Izuku moaned out, eyes nearly crossing in pleasure. "Ruin me, Kacchan. I wanna feel you for the next week—"

He knew those words challenged that competitive spirit in his husband.

Katsuki's eyes sharpened, and his lip twitched.

Then he adjusted for exactly half a second before he returned with a brutal snap. Izuku gasped excitedly, his body arching involuntarily into the next savage thrust. Katsuki's cock hit directly against the spot inside of him, washing his mind blank. Izuku's ragged breaths came in short bursts, and soon the room spun as pleasure-pain coiled tighter in his gut.

Katsuki shifted then, muscles flexing under Izuku's hands as he sat up in one fluid motion.

His arms wrapped around Izuku's waist, pulling them chest to chest. The heat of their bodies fused as he began thrusting like this, keeping Izuku deadlocked between overstimulation and pleasure.

Hot tears burned at the edges of Izuku's vision as Katsuki's mouth brushed his ear.

"Hold on to me," Katsuki commanded.

Izuku obeyed instinctively. His hands gripped Katsuki's shoulders, fingers sinking into the tense, corded muscles there. The new position pressed them impossibly closer, helping Katsuki's cock angle even deeper. Izuku sobbed with titillation as he clung for dear life. His nails bit into flesh as Katsuki's pace somehow quickened, hips snapping with unrelenting ferocity.

With effortless strength, Katsuki repositioned them further. He leaned forward, rolling them so he knelt between Izuku's spread thighs. The movement lifted Izuku slightly, but Katsuki's hands never left his hips, guiding him down onto that wide cock as he bounced him in his lap.

Izuku's legs draped over Katsuki's thighs, and he blinked rapidly. The impossible stretch burned anew, and the wet sounds of lube filled the room.

"*Kacchan*," Izuku cried as he tilted his head back.

Rapture consumed him, wave after wave swallowing his mind. His world filtered down to the relentless bounce and the grip on his hips. His curls stuck to his forehead as his throat laid exposed. He gasped and writhed, lost in the overwhelming tide.

Suddenly, Izuku felt it.

He noticed the way Katsuki's rhythm faltered and his grip on Izuku tightened like iron.

A low, desperate moan tore from Katsuki's throat.

"K-Kacchan," Izuku called again, purposefully clenching and begging to be filled. Katsuki stuttered, gasping and groaning. Izuku took the opportunity to be bold. He reached down and grasped one of Katsuki's hands. He guided it to his bare neck and closed it around his delicate throat. "*Please*. G-Give it to me more, I want it. Fuck me stupid—"

Suddenly, Katsuki surged forward.

He planted Izuku onto his back with a groan. Izuku hit the mattress flat, and the air whooshed from his lungs as Katsuki pinned him down.

The hand around his throat tightened into a lover’s chokehold, and Izuku choked happily with a smile.

“Anything your beautiful ass needs,” Katsuki snarled.

Without pause, Katsuki slammed back in, plowing into Izuku with brutal force. He applied pressure as the bed creaked under the surge. Izuku’s head went perfectly light as his legs wrapped around Katsuki’s waist.

His husband’s free hand found his in the chaos, and their fingers interlocked in a fierce grip.

Katsuki leaned down, hot breath mingling with Izuku’s in the scant space between their mouths. They were panting and gasping, with their lips brushing but not quite kissing. The insanity built tenfold as Izuku’s throat bobbed and gagged underneath Katsuki’s loving chokehold.

Izuku's moans turned into whimpers, then to short gasps. His body jolted with every rough thrust, and the mattress dipped and bunched beneath them like it might give way.

Katsuki got rougher, hips snapping faster, harder, and more out of control.

“Shit, darling,” he groaned in a strained voice. “You’re gonna make me cum.”

His eyes remained focused on Izuku’s flushed face, drinking him in. In response, Izuku could only nod. He was too lost in the haze. He arched as his own cock throbbed, trapped between their bodies as the mind numbing pleasure built higher and higher all down his nerves.

Suddenly, the pressure snapped all at once.

Izuku choked out a cry. His release crashed over him, and dots spotted his vision. His cock pulsed, ribbons of cum splattering across his chest. Katsuki followed a thrust later. He drove in as far as he could, burying himself to the hilt with a guttural groan. His hips seized as his cock began pumping hot cum, flooding Izuku’s tiny hole until it overflowed, trickling down his thighs.

They both collapsed, limbs tangled together. Katsuki’s full weight pressed Izuku into the mattress, a comforting blanket of sweat and heat. Under the lull, Izuku let his eyes flutter shut. He savored the bliss and aftershock that rolled through his body. Then he smiled subtly when Katsuki’s hand loosened to stroke his jaw tenderly.

After the comedown, Katsuki propped up on his elbows. He leaned over Izuku, grinned lazily as he stole a quick kiss.

They eventually cleaned up, then readjusted back to the head of the bed, snugly under the covers in the afterglow.

Nuzzled into the blankets, their fingers intertwined and their hearts spilled over with love. Izuku chuckled as Katsuki pushed back his sweat soaked bangs, and Katsuki blushed when Izuku kissed his nose. They curled up together, smiling under the silver light of the crescent moon.

Izuku put his hand over Katsuki's heart.

"Kacchan," he quietly asked, "What type of life do you think we're going to have?"

Katsuki smiled, as if the answer was obvious.

"Any life we have together will be a good life."

☽ ☽ ☾ ☾

First Year in Retirement

The first year passed by quieter than Katsuki thought it would.

At first, he'd assume it would come with an adjustment period. Y'know, those days with awkward pauses and rough transitions as the reality of it all hit them like a brick wall. But, instead, it was entirely the opposite. Smooth. Gentle. Somehow, effortlessly easy. It was sort of a surprise, but really, he should've known a life with his darling would've come so damn smoothly.

Their mornings were quiet. Their evenings were full of games. It was seamless in a way Katsuki didn't think was possible. Only on some days did he miss everyone from back home, especially Aizawa.

But when he did, he just called.

And he was always happy to catch up with his old man.

Waking up every morning next to Izuku was like stepping into a warm house after living too long in the cold. For the first few months, they kept to themselves. Izuku caught him up to speed on the local languages, while Katsuma adjusted to being in a new home. They didn't rush anything as they took time to adjust back into society without bloodstained hands.

During this period, Katsuma took to him quicker than expected. The little boy started mirroring a lot of his behavior and treated him like a cool live-in superhero. And soon, Katsuki figured out he sort of really liked being a caretaker.

It was healing to make sure Katsuma got the childhood he never was afforded.

He remembered the way their house felt that first spring: full of jubilance and the sound of hammering. They put together so much furniture he was positive he never wanted to look at another Ikea manual in his damn life.

They furnished their whole house in a way that truly spoke to both of their personal styles. Bookshelves lined the living room, and tall plants lounged around every corner. But more importantly, they decorated the halls with pictures. They put all his old photographs of his mother in special frames and hung them up in the hallways.

And right beside them, they placed their new family photos.

They accumulated a boatload of photos those first few months. Some examples included: Katsuma smiling, Katsuki cooking, and Izuku grinning with a book in his reading chair. They even took photos of their first day in the park together along with the days they spent in the backyard playing games.

“Kacchan, smile for me one more time!” Izuku giggled once.

Katsuki grumbled as the flash went off. “Don’t you think we’ve taken enough photos?”

“No such thing. Now smile again!”

He rolled his eyes half heartedly and grinned. His husband beamed brightly and kissed him on the cheek.

Katsuki never thought he’d ever have a home so full of love like this.

By the time summer rolled around, Izuku found work first.

His brilliant nerd began teaching private violin lessons and helping at a small local ensemble. Every evening he came home smelling of rosin and jasmine soap, cheeks flushed from the walk. And every evening Katsuki pretended like he wasn’t eagerly waiting on the couch with Katsuma for the sound of his keys.

Katsuki himself juggled small composing gigs.

Nothing too terribly fancy. It was stuff like commercials, indie films, and anything that paid decent enough. As long as he wasn’t bored to death, he was game. And even though the work was inconsistent, it was his. And that was enough to heal his inner child in more ways than he knew.

Everything was falling into place slowly.

Katsuma quickly grew into his place in the family. He was bright, excitable, and damn near fearless. Katsuki was surprised at how natural it felt to spend time with the kid. It was easy to read him like he were his flesh and blood. And somehow, all the pain from the past nimbly slipped away with the sound of a happy child’s laughter ricocheting down the halls.

But even with that, eventually Katsuki needed a healthy outlet for his anger—per the suggestion from their therapist.

He picked Muay Thai over meditation ultimately. Mainly because the idea of sitting still too long made his skin crawl. However, a physical outlet was perfect for him. In the gym, he found a great fucking release in the sweat and the sharp crack of his shin against the padded floor.

Eventually, Izuku and Katsuma came to watch his sparring matches. And Katsuma cheered like Katsuki was some kind of superhero.

“Go, Kacchan!” Katsuma would scream from Izuku’s lap. “You can do it!”

Izuku cheered too. His husband would look at him so adoringly the whole time with those big pretty green eyes. It wasn't before long that the three of them moved like a natural family. The other members at his gym frequently told him he had a cute kid and husband. And every time they did, he felt like the luckiest damn person in the world.

It was going *great*.

However, when the fall came around, Katsuki caught Izuku zoning out a lot.

Katsuma was officially enrolled at school, which meant they had more free time. Without the presence of an ever giggling toddler, something shifted. Katsuki would walk by in the halls and find Izuku listlessly lounging on the couch under a blanket. He'd be in a complete stupor, staring at Tomura's urn that was placed on a small pedestal by their fireplace mantel.

After that, Katsuki decided to make a risky suggestion.

They had been getting ready for bed. And directly after brushing their teeth, Izuku had been staring at his tattoo in the full length mirror. His fingers grazed that 217 while a pensive gaze resided in his eyes. It was damn near identical to how Hiryu used to look at his own tattoo.

Back then, Katsuki never understood what emotion was dancing in Hiryu's ink black eyes. But now, he got it.

It was grief.

Katsuki quietly came up behind Izuku. He carefully caressed his shoulders.

"You stare at that thing a lot," Katsuki pointed out.

"…Yeah," Izuku answered distantly. "It…It's been bringing up not so great memories. We're getting close to winter."

"Maybe it's time to get it covered up? But only if you want to."

Izuku blinked slowly, as if that idea never occurred to him.

"I could," he said quietly. "But I always felt like my number was a part of me…or more so, I was my number."

"You're far more than a number," Katsuki reminded him. "You always have been."

After that, they found a tattoo parlor.

Izuku sat in the chair nervously, holding his hand the whole time as the woman worked ink into his skin. He barely flinched as the new ink engulfed the old. And soon, that ugly 217 was swallowed up—gone forever.

What now sat valorously on Izuku's collarbone was a slain viper. The creature was coiled, snarling and stabbed straight through by a single dagger. It wove in and out on Izuku's collarbone, creating an optical illusion that it was weaving in and out of his skin.

“This is the sickest tattoo I’ve ever done,” the tattoo artist complimented. “A never would have thought about a Viper Killer design. Does it have any personal meaning?”

Izuku touched the swollen skin with a trembling thumb. “It does.”

Katsuki touched it too, pride swelling in his chest. “Now this is *much* better.”

☽ ☽ ☽

Second Year in Retirement

By the second year, the clay of their lives began to take shape.

Katsuma was settling into school, and he loved it. He was a little scared of the other kids at first, which Izuku assumed would happen. But steadily, the little guy realized no one was there to hurt him. And soon he was laughing and playing with the other kindergarteners.

In the meantime, Izuku discovered he had a talent for coaxing life out of plants. But not before killing half the damn garden first. Katsuma followed him everywhere, tiny boots tracking through the soil as he handed Izuku watering cans twice his weight or pointed out bugs with scientific fascination.

Katsuki often watched from the bench. He rested his chin on top of his knuckles as the two of them laughed in the sunlight. He really loved seeing Izuku brush dirt off Katsuma’s cheeks and Katsuma proudly hold up a crooked flower he plucked himself.

That same year, they discovered Katsuma had a distinct gift: he could sing.

It shocked the hell out of them.

It had been a quiet evening where Katsuki was resting on the couch while Izuku practiced a new number on the violin: *F. Chopin: Nocturne in C sharp minor*. Katsuki had been carefully listening to the way Izuku hit the notes for his own inspiration. He smirked a bit every time Izuku huffed and restarted the sections that gave him a bit more difficulty.

When Izuku began playing the most melodically pleasing section, a tiny voice bloomed from the next room.

Katsuki opened his eyes, thinking he must’ve misheard it—but he hadn’t. In the smallest voice, was Katsuma perfectly vocalizing along with Izuku.

Izuku nearly fumbled his bow.

Katsuki quickly waved his hand at Izuku to keep playing. Slowly, they both crept forward. They did their best to not disturb the atmosphere. And when they turned the corner, they found Katsuma singing to himself while doodling in his notebook.

Both of their mouths dropped.

After that, Katsuma's school started noticing too. His teachers were stunned at how well he grasped melody, pitch, and sound. It wasn't before long Izuku and Katsuki enrolled him in classes on the side for musically gifted children. Katsuki tried his best to not be too smug when the instructors pulled them aside to gush about Katsuma's potential.

And then came Katsuki's first professional break: a full-length composition commissioned by the city symphony.

He worked late into the night with his fingers stained with graphite. Countless stacks of sheet music were scattered across their kitchen table like fallen leaves as he tried to put together the first piece.

It looked like madness in the house those weeks. He was nervous and overly disorganized. But whenever he doubted himself, or felt himself slipping into that spiraling state of mind—Izuku was there. His husband gently reminded him that there was always beauty in madness. And that no matter what, he would do an amazing job.

And that support was enough for Katsuki to make it through.

When he perfected his first professional composition, he thought it was all a fever dream. He practiced it with the city symphony, and many of the musicians told him it was heartfelt enough to make them cry.

And when the night of the big performance arrived, they all dressed up as a family. They put Katsuma in a tiny button-up shirt that sparkled, and Izuku was radiant in an all black tux on Katsuki's arm. When they arrived, Izuku and Katsuma took their seats, leaving Katsuki alone with the orchestra. He prepped and fiddled with his cuff links as he took the stage.

It was a packed house.

Rows and rows of faces stared back at him, all dressed up to hear something *he* made.

And when the final note evaporated into silence, the applause rose like a wave. People stood, one after another, until the entire theater was on its feet. The thunderous claps overpowered his ears. He smiled and bowed as he fought the urge to cry from sheer joy. He felt like he was in one of his lucid dreams, living out something he only ever could imagine in the back of his mind.

Under the bright white glow of the spotlight, he searched the audience.

And there, in the front row, he found his husband.

Izuku stood clapping with both hands. He was wearing the proudest smile Katsuki had ever seen. Tears gathered at his lashes, glinting like tiny stars. Katsuma was beside him, bouncing with excitement, clapping so enthusiastically his hands barely stayed aligned.

Izuku mouthed to him, "I love you."

And Katsuki mouthed, "I love you too," right back.

☽ ☽ ☽

Third Year in Retirement

When the third year arrived, Katsuki couldn't believe so much time had passed.

How the hell had three years gone by? It felt like only a few months. But in the third year, they were fully in their stride. After his successful composition, the city symphony offered him a permanent composer-in-residence position.

He was fucking ecstatic. He got his own office and fancy name plaque. Katsuki made sure to celebrate with Izuku very specially that night. He sent Katsuma over to a friend's house and made sure his sexy husband hit inspiring, breathless high notes all damn night long.

After he got his new job, the good news kept rolling in.

Shortly after, Izuku applied and got a part time professor position at the National University of Singapore. It was perfect and complimented his other part time job as a violinist at the local ensemble. On his free days, he started working in the school of literature with an emphasis in romantic lit. His dorky course was entitled *'Echoes of Devotion: Romanticism & The Human Condition'* as he analyzed ancient and contemporary texts.

"Oh, those students are going to *flock* to you," Katsuki joked that night in their bedroom.

He was watching Izuku fuss over which tie to wear for his first day of teaching. Izuku, fully red in the face, spluttered at the implication and pushed his shoulder.

"No, they're not! Kacchan—"

"C'mon, you know it's true," Katsuki continued with a lopsided smirk. He leaned in and toyed with the loose tie. "You have the whole pretty boy thing going on. You're going to be the hot professor on campus. All the students are going to giggle whenever you blush. And you're not going to have a single damn problem holding *anyone's* attention."

"…I think you're overstating my pull."

"Sure I am." Katsuki sarcastically rolled his eyes. He grabbed the ugly purple tie and yanked his husband flush against his body. "C'mere, *sensei*. I think I need another lesson in my Mandarin tones—"

And after the first semester, just like Katsuki said, Izuku got known as the hot professor on campus.

And to no one's surprise, his classes quickly filled up.

With the new jobs and Katsuma excelling in school, there wasn't a single day Katsuki would say was bad.

Very often, they spent their summer nights in their backyard with the three of them beneath the sprawling Singapore sky. The fire pit glowed between them, casting gold across Izuku's

beautiful cheekbones and making Katsuma's wide grin even brighter.

Most nights were Katsuma telling them stories too fast to breathe. Katsuki would tease the boy until Izuku swatted his arm. But other nights were quiet. The gentle hush of the countryside would wrap around them as they laid on their backs counting constellations.

Katsuki remembered one night in particular.

Izuku had rested his head on Katsuki's shoulder, and on the other side, Katsuma had curled up into him. He wrapped his arm around them both and realized their breathing was in sync without even meaning to be.

They stayed like that for a fleeting moment.

And Katsuki wondered, if somewhere in the sky, his parents were watching over them. He knew they would be happy to see he was finally at rest too.

☽ ☽ ☽

Fourth Year in Retirement

The fourth year arrived without fanfare.

Katsuki only realized it arrived when he looked at the calendar that morning. He made an impressive hum to himself as Izuku whipped up pan pan pancakes and Katsuma helped pack all their lunches.

When he did notice it, the only feeling he had was the soft certainty that they were living a life they once thought was impossible.

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki leaned over the sheet music spread across his desk.

His pencil tapped in a restless rhythm against the margin before he dragged it into motion again. He scratched out a half measure, rewrote it, and then changed it again. He huffed as he chased the precise shape of a melody that kept hovering an inch out of reach of his imagination.

Around him, his office was entirely quiet save for the ticking clock. He settled deeper into flow, and soon the outside world shrank into nothing. Everything faded except the melody inside his head as his muscle memory worked with the familiar rhythm of creation.

He had just penciled in another shorthand chord when a knock tapped against the doorframe.

Katsuki blinked out of his trance. "Come in."

The door swung open to reveal one of the senior musicians. He was an older, broad-shouldered guy named Jun. He always had his hair tied back in a loose knot and a delighted smile on his lips.

“I hope I’m not interrupting the mad genius in action,” Jun said as he stepped inside.

Katsuki snorted. “I’m doing nothing but beating my head against a wall. What’s up?”

Jun lifted something from behind his back. It was a flat square, wrapped in crisp paper. Katsuki recognized its shape instantly.

“You got it?” he asked, grinning.

“Pressed it myself,” Jun said as he handed it over. “I kept the name obscured, just like you asked. By the way, I think this is going to make one hell of a gift.”

Katsuki peeled back the edge just enough to see the glossy black vinyl inside. It was perfectly unmarked except for a tiny gold symbol. He grinned, thinking about how much his husband was going to really fucking love this.

“Thanks, Jun, I really appreciate your help,” Katsuki said. He tucked it carefully into his bag.

Jun laughed from his belly. “You did all the hard work, Taro! I can’t wait to hear about how much Hiroji loved it.”

Katsuki grinned. “He’s gonna lose his damn mind.”

When Jun wandered off, Katsuki checked the clock. Damn. It was later than he thought. Quickly, he stood up and began to gather his things. He glanced fondly at the framed photo on his desk of him, Izuku and Katsuma together. It was a quick picture they captured right before Katsuma’s first day of 3rd grade.

He packed his notebooks into the sleek briefcase that was embossed with their surname ‘Bakugou’. His darling had gifted it to him when he got the new job—and Katsuki made sure to use it every day.

He threw on his black wool overcoat and made his way out to the parking lot.

He hopped in their family SUV and began to drive down a route he had memorized by heart. He drove with one hand on the wheel, humming the melody he’d been working on. His mind was entirely serene as he let the sunlight warm the side of his face.

Soon a familiar university came into view.

When he pulled into a space near the front, a woman with black hair immediately waved from the walkway.

“Maestro Bakugou!” She called, laughing as she approached. “Right on time as always. I wish my lazy boyfriend was half as punctual as you are.”

Katsuki leaned out the window, smirking. “Hey there, Li Hua! How’s everything going?”

“Good, good. Same ol’ same old. My students have been a handful this year, but that’s the life I chose. How about you?”

“Pretty much the same,” he said simply. “I’m here to pick up my husband, like always.”

She rolled her eyes fondly. “Then you’ll need to go to his office. Hiroji’s up there drowning in papers. Poor man hasn’t looked up once in the last two hours.”

Katsuki sharply laughed. “Figures. He’s been like that since the day I met him.”

Li Hua waved him off as she continued walking. When she was out of view, he slung his bag over his shoulder and began his trek across campus.

He took the familiar path lined with jacaranda trees. He hummed his new melody as he idyllically walked across the scattered purple blossoms under his shoes.

Along the way, a few students called his name, waving enthusiastically. Katsuki lifted a hand and returned a small smile. He recognized a couple of them because they were music majors. A lot of the orchestra students got to know him through internships at the city symphony.

When he reached Izuku’s floor, he stopped in front of the wooden door he’d seen too many times to count. He smiled to himself as he read the neat plaque that inscribed: *Mr. Bakugou Hiroji — Literature Department.*

Katsuki only knocked once and pushed the door open with his shoulder.

There, his darling sat at his desk basked in afternoon sun. His octagonal glasses were perched low on his nose as he scribbled notes across the margin of a student’s exam. Katsuki cracked a grin when he noticed how damn messy Izuku’s hair was. Probably from the nerd running his hand through it subconsciously over and over.

Obnoxiously, Katsuki slammed the door and locked it tight behind him.

The sound jogged Izuku out of his grading trance. He startled upright and snapped his head towards the door.

And immediately his entire face illuminated.

“Kacchan,” Izuku said, beaming so brightly Katsuki felt it infect him too. He then glanced at the clock, and a tiny gasp escaped him. “Oh *shit*—I’m sorry! I completely lost track of time.”

“Yeah, yeah, I can see that.”

Katsuki walked around the desk and stood over Izuku. With a toothy grin, he reached down and plucked the glasses right off Izuku’s cute nose. His husband blinked up at him, slightly blushing.

“But I know you can’t help but be a big dork,” Katsuki teased.

Right as Izuku was about to retort, Katsuki leaned down and kissed him.

Their lips met in a soft press. Katsuki smiled into it, and he could feel Izuku calmly begin too as well. He took his time, molding his mouth perfectly to Izuku’s fuller one. Then he

breathed in the pleasant exhale Izuku expelled. It was light and tender, just like the life they had built together.

Izuku's hands slid up Katsuki's chest and Katsuki hummed happily as he deepened the kiss. His free hand cupped the back of Izuku's neck, thumb stroking the skin there in lazy circles. The kiss turned languid, and Izuku melted into it with a soft sigh.

"You're terrible," Izuku murmured. "I can't come up with a witty reply when you kiss me like that."

"Mhm. You love it," Katsuki replied. His low voice vibrated through their joined lips. He brushed his thumb along Izuku's cheek, tracing his freckles tenderly. Then he pulled back just an inch and with exaggerated seriousness said, "It's okay, sensei. I forgive you for being a nerd."

Izuku's laugh was breathy and sweet. His head tipped back slightly as Katsuki kissed the corner of his jaw.

"Y'know…" Katsuki hooked a finger under Izuku's tie. "We've got thirty minutes before we have to pick up Katsuma."

Izuku's eyes clouded instantly. "Thirty whole minutes?"

"Mhm. Plenty of time for a quickie," Katsuki murmured, peppering kisses along Izuku's neck. "If we're quick."

Izuku nodded so fast Katsuki was sure he turned dizzy. "Go lock the door."

Katsuki grinned. "Already did."

☽ ☽ ☽

He leaned back in the driver's seat, one hand draped over the wheel as Izuku limped into the car with rose colored cheeks. His curls were a little mussed, and his tie was loosened in a sloppy way that made Katsuki's mouth twitch with smug satisfaction.

The moment Izuku settled in, Katsuki reached over and buckled the seatbelt for him. Along the way, he palmed Izuku's hip a little too deliberately. Immediately, his cutie of a husband swatted his hand, slightly embarrassed, but didn't stop grinning.

By the time they pulled up to Katsuma's school, Izuku had composed himself enough to look like a respectable adult—mostly. Blush still clung to the tips of his ears.

Katsuma barreled out of the school gates the second he spotted the car. He came running with his backpack bobbing and hair sticking up in every direction. He yanked open the back door and launched himself inside.

"Hi!" he greeted, excited. "Guys! Today was *awesome*!"

Izuku twisted in his seat. "Oh, yeah?! What happened?"

And that was all Katsuma needed to start rambling, clearly something he picked up from Izuku. He exploded into rapid-fire recollection, recounting every detail from his day. He explained how he'd painted a giant nebula in art class and then raced a classmate during recess. Then he rounded his story off with how his teacher had given him the lead in the school choir.

Izuku soaked in every word. He was smiling so wide his cheeks must've hurt.

He kept asking gentle questions while Katsuki injected with spurts of encouragement. Both of them laughed loudly whenever Katsuma got especially animated. Katsuki listened the entire ride home, glancing at Katsuma in the rearview mirror warmly.

As Katsuma talked about gym class, Katsuki's mind wandered back to the day's date. He measured the Katsuma he saw now against the quiet one he first met. And damn, he was proud of who the kid was becoming. Katsuma spoke freely and was incredibly intelligent.

And Katsuki was sure he got that from Izuku.

He glanced at Izuku when they reached a red light. His husband laughed loudly at a joke Katsuma made, and Katsuki smiled at the sound.

☽ ☽ ☽

"No running!" Katsuki yelled as Katsuma scampered down the hall.

"Sorry, Kacchan!" Katsuma shouted back as he turned the corner. "I *really* have to pee!"

Katsuki sighed as Katsuma's red backpack slid across the wooden floors.

Izuku laughed as he took his shoes off. "You know he does that every day, you always act so surprised."

"I know, I just don't want the brat to slip and hurt himself. I do not want to go to the hospital again tonight."

They settled into their routine the next moment. Katsuma came back and grabbed his bag with a grin as Izuku drifted towards the couch.

Katsuki watched as Izuku took out his laptop with a soft sigh and brought out his stack of papers to grade. Beside him, Katsuma kicked his feet up and began working on his homework, idly asking questions in between lulls of silence. Izuku answered him without looking up, big ass brain fully on display.

When he felt content, Katsuki slipped into the kitchen. He rolled up his sleeves and began preparing a meal he knew would make both of his bundles of sunlight smile. He hummed lightly to himself, still mentally working on his newest commission in the back of his mind.

Floating in from the living room, he could hear Katsuma muttering through his spelling words and Izuku groaning whenever he hit a particularly tricky rubric note.

When dinner was finally ready, the house smelled of ginger and garlic.

The three of them gathered at the table with steaming plates of food. Katsuma dove in cheerfully, talking between bites. Izuku smiled at nearly everything he said, eyes soft from the long day. And Katsuki chimed in with dry remarks that made both of them snort.

If ever asked, Katsuki would say he loved this part of his day the most.

While he liked his work, he enjoyed this time with his family more.

When the plates were cleared, Katsuma brought his homework to the table and glanced at Katsuki shyly.

“Can you help me with my math homework?” He asked with a snag-a-tooth grin. “I’m having a little trouble with some of the harder questions.”

“Of course, buddy,” Katsuki said, holding out a hand.

Katsuma passed him the worksheet, and Katsuki glanced over it. He digested it easily, pointing out how to break down the problem.

Across the table, Izuku watched them fondly. And then after a while, he walked over to his briefcase and pulled out a small folder. Katsuki didn’t glance up until he heard the sound of card stock shifting. He peeked over—then paused.

“You’re still finalizing the guest list?” Katsuki asked. “I thought you finished it last week.”

Izuku glanced at him and shyly smiled. “Nana got back to me today about one more person she located. She was tough to track down, but Nana found her. And I really want her to come. I would genuinely love for you to meet her.

“Remind me, what’s her name again?”

“Ochako,” Izuku said with a radiant glint in his eye. “I just have to send this to her, and we’re all set.”

Katsuki grinned as Izuku leaned forward, hunching over the tiny invite. He prepped it exactly how the others were, using a small box of pressed flowers and golden ink. His husband began decorating the paper, carefully brushing delicate accents along the borders, his brows furrowed in concentration.

And when he finished, he held it up for Katsuki and Katsuma to see.

They both smiled as they read the calligraphy.

You are warmly invited to the wedding of Bakugou Taro and Hiroji.

We hope to see you there.

Chapter End Notes

Please let me know what you think!! Next chapter is the long awaited ceremony between these two lovebirds :') 💕💕💕💕 Thank you all so much for reading 🤍

Chapter 53: Coda

Chapter Summary

> Coda (definition) — A passage that brings a musical piece to an end. It may be as simple as a few measures, or as complex as an entire section.

Chapter Notes

> Hello everyone :) welcome to the very special finale! I'm so happy you're here. I won't put too much here, because all my thoughts are all scribbled down below. Of course, big thank you to the LOML, Luna, for betaing like always 💜💜💜 I hope you enjoy 🤍

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 53 — Coda

.

.

.

Fifth Year in Retirement

Katsuki stood in front of the dressing room mirror, muttering loudly.

His jaw clamped tight as his fingers worked his cufflinks. These damn things kept slipping—or maybe his hands were shaking. But he'd never admit the latter to anyone alive.

His tie, a blush pink, that Izuku managed to smooth talk him into, was ironed out within an inch of its life. But he ran his sweaty palms down the front once more anyways. When he flattened the tie to his liking, he moved on to his black tux and muttered loudly when he found a wrinkle.

"Dude," Denki groaned.

Katsuki cut his eye at him through the mirror. His friend was sitting cross-legged on the small couch behind him, laughing with a mouthful of mints he'd stolen from the welcome table.

"Bakugou, at this point you're going to rip your tie if you keep fussing with it," Denki lectured. "*Relax*. If Izuku wanted to run away from you, he would have done so a long, *long*

time ago."

"Shut up, Pikachu," Katsuki snapped, glowering at his reflection. "It's my wedding. I need to make sure I don't look like a clown."

"But bro, you're fine," Denki insisted. "You look like the kind of guy who charges by the minute to stand there and just be hot."

Beside Denki, Shinsou sighed. He was lounging backwards with all the boredom of a house cat. He raised a brow and side-eyed Katsuki.

"Looks wise, Denki's right," Shinsou said dryly. "What I'm more concerned about is the muttering. You sound like you're doing incantations in the mirror."

Katsuki shot him a glare too but didn't stop mumbling as he straightened the lapel. "It's a habit I've picked up from Izuku. That nerd mutters to himself around the house all day long. He's even got Katsuma doing it."

"Oh, my god." Denki giggled in delight. "Wait, that's adorable! A family of mutterers!"

Shinsou tilted his head, and a lazy grin spread across his face. "So he infected you with nervous rambling. Cute. What'd he pick up from you?"

"You should hear the way he curses now," Katsuki chuckled. He snapped the cufflink into place with more force than necessary and turned towards his friends. "He sounds like a goddamn sailor these days. It makes me so proud I could cry."

Denki wheezed. "So you taught the world's sweetest man how to say 'fuck' in twelve different emotional registers?"

"Damn right I did." Katsuki grinned. "And I can't wait to see what more we'll teach each other."

"Save it for the vows," Monoma injected abruptly, walking in through the door with Sero. "I don't mean to rush you at all, but the ceremony is about to start in ten minutes. And if I remember correctly, I was tasked with keeping everyone in order because I am, and I quote, the wielder of the biggest stick up their ass?"

The room broke out in familiar, juvenile snickers.

When the tide of mirth settled down, Katsuki sighed. He turned to the mirror one last time and ran a hand through his hair. He did so carefully, so he didn't mess up the stylist's handiwork.

"Okay, okay," Katsuki groaned, feeling heat rise in his throat again. "I'll get a move on. I…I just want it to be perfect."

And to his surprise, no jokes followed. None of his friends teased him, and instead they patiently waited for him to calm down.

Without warning, the door creaked open, and everyone's head turned.

Katsuki's heart warmed when he spotted Aizawa in the doorway.

His old man blinked once, then twice, like the sight of Katsuki as a groom was the key to recalibrate his entire worldview. Everyone quieted as he walked forward. When he stopped right in front of Katsuki, a grin wider than anything any of them had ever seen graced his face.

"Retirement looks great on you, kid," he finally said.

"Thanks," Katsuki replied, eyes shining.

Aizawa reached into the inner pocket of his suit and pulled out a carefully wrapped corsage. It was the soft pink carnation with baby's breath that Izuku had made the night before for them. Aizawa opened the small box, stepped closer, and pinned it to Katsuki's suit jacket.

"You know, out of everything, this is the biggest surprise," Aizawa said, leaning back to inspect his work. "Once upon a time, I never thought I'd see you in anything other than black on black."

"Me too." Katsuki grinned lopsidedly. "Surprisingly, I didn't hate the pink when I tried it for the first time." He brushed his fingers over the pink carnation, and could hear the faint melody of his mother's laughter. "And, uh…turns out I like pink. It brings up good memories."

Aizawa's mouth tugged up.

Sero then walked up to him and slung his arm around his shoulders.

"I gotta say, Bakugou," he started with a bright grin. "We're all surprised it took you two this long to have a proper wedding. Why'd you wait so long?"

Katsuki shrugged. "We wanted to make sure it was safe first. It was important to us that everyone who mattered could be there."

"Aw, that's so heartwarming," Denki piped up. "But wow. Who knew you two had so many friends!"

"It's less than thirty people," Katsuki deadpanned.

"Exactly!" Denki laughed. "Color me impressed!"

Katsuki shook his head but chuckled. As familiar laughter circled around the room, his nerves calmed ever so slightly. Subdued excitement replaced some of his jittering, and he steadied himself while looking at his friends.

"Okay, it's time," Monoma said, slapping his shoulder. "Let's get this killer married."

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki edged up to the curtain and drew the fabric back by an inch.

The rooftop garden was staged exactly as Izuku planned. All around, soft pastels swept through the space in breathtaking harmony. Pink, orange, blue, and green drifted through the draped curtains and across the tables. Petals of pink carnations lay scattered over the floor, leading toward the aisle. And waiting there were rows of golden chairs flanking a long white runner that was as pristine as fresh snowfall.

Everyone was already seated and dressed in the spring palette they requested for the guest attire. The entire crowd glowed in bright colors that made the space feel like the first inhale of fresh air. And above it all, the sun hovered on the brink of descent. It was not quite a sunset, only slightly washing the sky in pinks and amber.

Katsuki's gaze swept anxiously over the scene.

He watched as his mixed-matched friends took their seats, and their other colorful guests chatted casually. Then somewhere in the first row, Nana caught him peeking. She lifted her hand in a graceful little wave.

Katsuki gave a stiff return wave before retreating behind the curtain.

And then—

The first notes of a violin drifted into the air.

A viola followed perfectly on cue. The melody grew, budding into a romantic ballad that hushed the chattering crowd.

Katsuki drew in one last breath, nerves spiking. He closed his eyes and tried to calm himself. Without saying a word, he touched the pink carnation above his heart. He felt his mother's presence and could feel her comforting hands steady him.

And as he imagined her, an actual hand rested firmly on his shoulder.

He half turned, and there was Aizawa, ready to go. His old man nodded at him once, and they exchanged brief nods.

"Ready?" Aizawa asked.

"Ready," Katsuki replied.

And with a leap of faith, they crossed the threshold.

The sound of the strings amplified, and the soft golden sun spilled across their faces. Katsuki smiled as all eyes turned to them. Aizawa held his head high as he walked beside Katsuki down the aisle. And through it all, Katsuki felt the presence of his parents too. He could sense his mother and father holding his hand from the other side, guiding him.

The wedding guests rose row by row as they passed down the aisle.

Several familiar faces came into focus: the loony old violinist, the Midnight Sento workers, and their colorful Paradise Crew from Okinawa.

Katsuki grinned as Kirishima and Mina excitedly waved from their seats next to Momo and Jirou. He then saw Shouto and Inasa sitting in the crowd, smiling at them too. Sekijiro and Nemuri's eyes lit up as he passed. And then Takeyama and Ryuko wiped tears from their eyes. He even spotted some of their new friends they've made in Singapore. Several of Izuku's work friends were here, and half of the city symphony staff had joined.

By the time he reached the officiant's side, his heart felt too big for his chest.

Aizawa took his seat next to Miruko and coolly folded his hands. Katsuki straightened his cufflinks once more and double-checked that his tie was straight. And soon as he finished, the music shifted.

It transformed into airy notes, as if the dusk itself began to sing.

Katsuki looked up. And his whole world stilled.

Izuku appeared at the end of the aisle, but not alone. Katsuma walked beside him, dressed in a tiny pink suit and white tie. His small fingers clasped tightly around Izuku's, and he had the biggest grin on his face.

And Izuku—

Oh, *Izuku*.

His darling remained the most magnificent man he's ever laid eyes on.

He matched Katsuki in a black tux, blush-pink tie, and a pink carnation corsage pinned above his heart. His dark curls framed his face, catching the fading light. He glowed beneath the sinking sun, honey-kissed skin richer from five years in the tropics.

And Izuku's gorgeous eyes drifted to him the way a tide always follows the moon.

The sight comforted Katsuki so quickly that all his nerves vanished.

His whole body loosened, soothed into a stillness only Izuku could give to him. And as his love moved down the aisle toward him, Katsuki wondered why he'd been so nervous at all. It had always been Izuku at the end of every road he'd chosen. And it would always be Izuku, the man he would chase through hell a thousand times to simply hold his hand.

Katsuki didn't even realize he was crying until the tears slipped free.

And as always, Izuku mirrored him. His darling let out a breathless, nervous laugh as he cried too.

Then, Izuku was standing right in front of him, close enough to touch. Katsuma peeled away toward his seat beside Nana, leaving the two of them standing at the altar underneath the arch of pink flowers.

Katsuki raised his hand at the same time Izuku did. Their thumbs brushed each other's cheeks, wiping away tears neither bothered to hide. And as they looked into each other's eyes, everything around Katsuki disappeared, leaving only Izuku as the center of his universe.

Katsuki never wanted to take his eyes off him.

The officiant began as the violin and viola faded off.

"Family, friends, and all gathered here to witness this union," she began. Her eyes scintillated as she glanced between the two lovers. "We stand under the open sky, in the last golden breath of the day, to celebrate a love that has endured but always persisted."

Katsuki held Izuku's hands as they looked into each other's eyes.

"Love," the officiant continued, "is not simply the warmth that blooms in the heart. It is discipline, courage, and devotion. It is the willingness to grow beside another soul and hold their darkness, their light, their sorrow, and their joy. Today, you vow not only to love, but to choose each other over and over, every day forward."

He turned to Izuku. "Hiroji, your vows."

Izuku kept his gaze focused on Katsuki's like nothing else existed.

"Taro," he said, and Katsuki broke into a small smile at their false names. "You have seen me at my worst and still offered me a place at your side. You have forgiven me in ways that can only come from someone with a pure, loving heart. Because even when I can't forgive myself, you're there to remind me I'm worth more than the bad things I've done. You chose me long before I ever believed I was worth choosing."

Izuku's breath shuddered as he continued.

"And I vow to always grow with you," he said with a smile. "Even when growth is painful. I vow to live, truly *live*, because you taught me that surviving is not the same as being alive. And I vow to stay, not out of obligation, but because my heart has always known that being beside yours is where it belongs."

Izuku's voice wavered slightly. More tears slipped freely down his cheeks.

"I vow to be your partner, your equal, and your home. Today and every day that follows."

Katsuki's throat tightened so hard he nearly choked. Around them, several guests were already sniffling. Katsuma openly wiped his face with both sleeves.

"Lovely," the officiant said with a smile. She then gave Katsuki a nod. "Taro, now your vows."

Katsuki drew a sharp breath. It took all he had to keep his voice steady as he cupped Izuku's hands inside his own.

“Hiroji,” he said lovingly. “You saved me from a life where I thought being strong meant sitting in solitude and anger. You taught me that loving someone doesn’t make you weaker, and that romance is one of the most beautiful, intimate things another person can give to you. And you showed me that love can forge you into someone who is wise, and that is what actual strength is.”

Katsuki swallowed hard and smiled.

“And I promise to protect you, but not because you need a shield. But because loving you means protecting the world we’re choosing to build together. I promise to fight to be better, every damn day, because you deserve the best version of me.”

Katsuki affectionately squeezed Izuku’s hands.

“And I promise,” he continued slightly softer, “to love you fiercely. I want to continue building a life with you where softness isn’t wrong. I want you to always feel certain that you can be gentle, without ever having to question if you should be.”

A tear escaped him.

“I vow to stand with you, darling,” he rasped. “I’ll walk beside you in every ugly, beautiful, terrifying, and brilliant moment of our lives. You are my partner. My future. My fate. And I will always find my way back to you, again and again…”

“…and again,” Izuku finished with him. “And I promise to always come back to you too.”

The entire crowd broke down in tears with them. Nana was openly dabbing her face with a handkerchief, Denki was crying uncontrollably into Shinsou’s shoulder, and Aizawa subtly brushed at his eyes. Even Nemuri tried her best not to cry off her mascara but was failing miserably.

“May we have the rings?” the officiant asked gently.

Katsuma hopped forward. He held up a tiny box, and sitting inside on a small silk cushion were two simple golden rings that matched the metal of their eternity rings. Katsuki picked up one first, and his hands didn’t shake.

He slid the golden ring onto Izuku’s finger, stacking it perfectly on top of the eternity ring made of rubies. Izuku took the second ring and slipped it onto Katsuki’s finger, mirroring the same with the eternity ring made of emeralds.

And when they were done, their ring fingers shone as brightly as their devotion.

The officiant smiled. “By the power entrusted to me, I pronounce you husbands! You may kiss!”

Katsuki didn’t wait to be told twice.

Right as the sun set, they both leaned in at the same time. Exquisite golden light spilled over them as their lips met and the crowd erupted into cheers.

Katsuki kissed Izuku as if he were made of precious memories. He stroked his cheek like he were touching him for the first time. It was an eloquent, majestic kiss and soft in a way that Katsuki knew he could be with his husband. Izuku's eyes drifted shut, and he gingerly tilted his head to kiss Katsuki deeply. Izuku threaded his fingers carefully through blond hair, letting himself get carried through the kiss like a ship carried off into the endless abyss.

When they finally parted, they were glowing the same as the glorious horizon.

All around them, shouts, applause, and laughter filled the atmosphere. Several people demanded an encore, and others whistled loudly.

But Katsuki only saw Izuku.

And Izuku only saw him.

☽ ☽ ☽

Night had settled over the rooftop garden, and fairy-lights swallowed the last traces of dusk. Strings of gentle golden bulbs wove between the trellises, lighting the tables in an intimate glow. Sea air drifted through the venue, carrying the muted sound of waves far below.

Katsuki and Izuku were at the head table, privately laughing between each other with their hands intertwined.

Around them, all their wedding guests sat with freshly warm plates of their dinner. They had picked out something they thought everyone would like: coconut cashew chicken as a starter with salad. And for the main course, grilled lemon chicken accompanied by roasted potatoes and seasoned vegetables.

Katsuki grinned as he took a swig of 'his' signature cocktail for the evening. It was a spicy grapefruit paloma that was tinted orange. In contrast, Izuku's signature drink was a pink and red 'sex on the beach' cocktail. All their wedding guests got to choose either or, and from the look of it, it was split down the middle in popularity.

As the dinner moved on with live music from the small live ensemble, Katsuki leaned over and whispered in Izuku's ear.

"Whenever you're ready, you can start the speeches," he said.

Izuku nodded and grabbed his cup. With a graceful pose, he stood up and clinked his fork against his glass. The response he got was a chorus of clinks and yelps from their group cheering and smiling at them. When Izuku raised his cup, the whole rooftop quieted down.

"Taro and I wanted to thank you all for coming," Izuku announced with a handsome smile. "We couldn't have imagined this day without you—any of you." He turned and beamed at all their guests. "I've been dreaming of this day ever since I first laid eyes on my husband here, when we were only seven years old."

He laughed, and a couple of chuckles bounced around.

“Back then, I thought it meant we got to spend all our time together,” Izuku continued. “And that was enough for little me. But now that we’re actually here, I realize younger me wasn’t too far off. There’s no one in the world I would rather spend all my days with.”

Katsuki stood next, grinning like a fool. He took Izuku’s hand in his and lifted his glass.

“That’s a bit of a hard one to follow,” Katsuki joked, and a couple of laughs chimed in. “I’m sure everyone knows by now Hiroji is the one who’s better with words. But we wanted to open the floor to all of you for speeches. We know some of you have something prepared, so we wanted to give you all the chance to go crazy.”

“But not too crazy!” Izuku amended with a sheepish smile. “Please keep it PG! We have a ten year old here—”

“I am nearly *eleven*!” Katsuma shouted.

“Point still stands,” Izuku shot back sternly.

Everyone laughed, and in the midst of the commotion, Aizawa stood first.

He walked to the center of the small dance floor and looked around. Everyone quieted as he cleared his throat and held up his cup.

“I’ll do my best to keep this short,” Aizawa began. He looked at Katsuki first, then Izuku. “I’ve watched you two survive more than most people could bear, and still you pushed on. You rebuilt your life into something more beautiful than ever imaginable.” His mouth twitched in an attempt at a smile. “I can’t wait for all your new adventures. You’ve both made me unbelievably proud of how far you’ve come.”

The crowd applauded, hushed but heartfelt.

Then suddenly, Monoma stood with a smug look. Katsuki scoffed, and the two of them exchanged innocuous eye rolls that were filled with brotherly affection.

“Alright, my turn,” Monoma announced, posing himself in the most obnoxious way imaginable. “I want to say, I’m so glad you two got your happy ending. I knew from the way you two looked at each other that it was meant to be. And like Kat—I mean *Taro*.” He grimaced. “Like *Taro* said earlier, a bond like this is worth protecting. If anyone thinks they can jeopardize your peace now—I’ll break their legs. And their arms.” He paused and tilted his head thoughtfully. “And probably their spirits. So. Cheers to you.”

Shouto and Inasa exchanged bewildered, worried glances.

Sero laughed loudly while Denki and Shinsou chuckled. A handful of guests applauded like this was exactly what they expected of him. But their friends from Okinawa and here in Singapore were clearly perplexed. Nevertheless, they clapped with the rest of the crowd as Monoma took his seat.

Denki stood next, already blotting his oncoming tears with a napkin.

“Man, where to even begin.” He sniffed. He raised his glass with a trembling hand. “I mean, look at you guys. You’re like, so in *love*!” He sobbed and sighed dreamily. “Taiwan feels like only yesterday. Back then, you two couldn’t even be in the same room without making others fear for their safety.” His voice pitched upward. “I’m so happy for you!”

He burst into another round of tears, and several tables laughed affectionately.

Next, Nana stood.

She didn’t raise her glass right away. Instead, she studied Izuku. Then she shifted her gaze to Katsuki.

“Taro and Hiroji,” she began tenderly. “I’m so happy to see how far you two have come. I tried to write this speech several times over and over, and it ended up being several pages too long. But what I want to say is, I hope your marriage is full of calm nights, and cheerful mornings. I hope you have more happy memories than you could ever count, and I’m so glad I got to help a love like this come true.”

Both Izuku and Katsuki bowed their heads to her. She lifted her glass, and they returned the gesture.

And finally, a small, brown-haired woman stood up.

She had rosy cheeks and chestnut-colored eyes. The tears in her eyes resembled tiny stars as her floral print dress swayed with the wind. She nervously took to the center of the floor with her drink. Her eyes landed on Izuku, and that’s when Katsuki realized that this must’ve been Ochako.

“I wasn’t sure if I should speak,” she began softly. “Taro, it’s great to finally meet you.”

Katsuki laughed and raised his glass. “Likewise.”

She looked at Izuku with soft, adoring eyes.

“Hiroji,” she whispered. “I’m so glad to see you again. Words can’t capture how much joy it brings me to see you. And it brings me even more joy to see you standing with the love of your life.” She turned her gaze to Katsuki. “I never believed in fairytales. I…I cast all that aside when I was young and saw how harsh the world was. But when I met Hiroji—”

She paused and blinked away the tears.

“The way he spoke about you, Taro, it made me think love was real,” Ochako whispered. “And if someone were to ask me if soulmates exist, you two would be the first example as proof I would use.” She raised her glass. “To a love that always finds its way back home.”

Everyone’s glasses lifted and overlapping voices mingled. And all around, the rooftop glowed in the light of love and happiness.

“To Hiroji and Taro,” Ochako toasted.

And everyone clinked their drinks and roared.

“I think it’s time for the first dance!” Sero shouted, and a loud whoop followed from Denki.

Katsuki and Izuku laughed but still made their way to the center of the dance floor. Right when they were directly in the middle, someone in the crowd got up. When Katsuki focused on the figure, it was Souta.

The loony elder man was far more hunched than the last time they saw him, but still fairly energetic. Katsuki was more than happy Souta responded to their letter, and it felt like the final touch on their wedding.

Souta’s eyes crinkled as he strolled over to the orchestra and picked up the spare violin.

“And now, I will play my all time favorite composition,” Souta announced. “It is called *The Dance of The Lovebirds*. Without Taro and Hiroji, it would have never been made. This is my gift to them, for the rest of their lives.”

He closed his eyes, lifted his instrument and the mood shifted. Ethereal waves of sound careened through the rooftop, and behind him the singular viola joined him. Their instruments spun together in the night air, making the song that brought them together.

And the two lovebirds danced.

Katsuki slipped one hand around Izuku’s waist, drawing him into the passionate rhythm of the music. Izuku’s free hand found Katsuki’s shoulder. They twirled, completely swept away. Every step they took with the inflection felt like floating through the stars. Their foreheads brushed. Their breaths mingled. And behind them, the endless city lights twinkled in harmony with the constellations above.

Izuku grinned serenely as Katsuki guided him through a turn. His eyes reflected the moon above as he stared up at Katsuki.

“This feels unreal after such a long time,” Izuku whispered.

Katsuki pulled his darling husband close enough that their chests pressed together. Their hearts lined up in perfect sync to make a single, unified rhythm. Katsuki rested his head on Izuku’s and smiled continually as they swayed.

“We were worth the wait,” Katsuki murmured.

The orchestra played on. Their song rose with overwhelming emotion as they floated through the starlit garden.

☽ ☽ ☽

Katsuki and Izuku stood pressed together in front of a wedding cake. It was three tiers of white, gold, and the shade of pink that matched their ties. It had edible glitter all around its edges, and crowning it was a cluster of sugar made pink carnations.

Everyone cheered loudly in sheer excitement as they picked up the knife together at the same time.

Izuku placed his hand over Katsuki's, guiding the knife through their wedding cake with a blissful smile. The moment they pressed down together, the crowd flared up with encouragement and whistles.

Miruko shouted, "Good job not crushing the cake, Taro!"

Sero immediately followed with, "Yeah. You're really a reformed man now!"

Katsuki rolled his eyes, and Izuku laughed. His husband leaned into him as they maneuvered together seamlessly. When they pulled back, the slice came away a perfect slice. The staff then divided the cake, and smiles gleamed all around as the dessert was served, devoured, and praised with sticky fingers.

Izuku took a delicate bite of the cake and lit up instantly. "The strawberry was a perfect choice."

"Of course you'd say that," Katsuki laughed as he sampled his own slice. "You're obsessed with strawberries."

"And you're obsessed with Boston doughnuts," Izuku shot back. He jutted his chin towards the dessert table where an entire pyramid of them sat stacked. "Tell me, was it really necessary to dedicate an entire table to your addiction?"

Katsuki's grin sharpened. "What can I say?" He plucked the one from his plate and sank his teeth into it. He then squeezed it just enough for the custard to spill over his thumb. "I've always *loved* a good cream filling."

Izuku shoved his playfully shoulder, laughing. "You're so crude."

After that, the night deepened and the proper celebration ignited.

Upbeat, deafening pop music pulsed through the venue's speakers. Rich bass flooded beneath the lively lyrics. All their guests spilled onto the dance floor and intermingled.

Katsuki snickered as Mina dragged Shinsou by his wrist when she spotted him standing by himself. Off to the side, Shouto attempted to sway with a rhythmic stiffness that made Inasa beam with pride. Denki spun Sero around until both nearly toppled onto a table.

Katsuki and Izuku barely made it three steps onto the dance floor before they were intercepted.

"Surprise!" Mina squealed, appearing with Eijiro beside her. Both of their hands were hidden behind their back. "We got you guys a very special present! We couldn't wait to see your faces, so we wanted to show you now!"

Both Izuku and Katsuki's eyebrows shot up, and they grinned in amusement.

“Sure thing!” Izuku laughed. “Let’s see it!”

Then, with all the theatrical flair of a Broadway cast, Mina and Eijiro at the same time revealed glittering white tracksuits, one in each of their hands. Katsuki’s face fell, appalled when he caught sight of the sparkly bedazzled letters that were positioned straight across the backside.

On one pair it read: **NEWLY**.

And on the other: **WEDS**.

Izuku choked, and Katsuki shook his head.

“Absolutely fucking not,” Katsuki said curtly, putting his hand up. “Those things are hideous.”

“I actually think they’re perfect,” Izuku said while hysterically laughing. “Thank you! Really. Thank you both so much!”

Katsuki whirled on his husband as Izuku, the damn traitor, grabbed the one in his size. Izuku grinned gratefully at the Ashido-Kirishimas, who were grinning triumphantly.

“We figured you’d need something empowering and manly!” Eijiro chuckled with a puffed out chest. “We made it just for you! It’s a one-of-a-kind set, so you two can look like the power couple you are when you hit the gym!”

Katsuki muttered, “Yeah, because nothing says ‘power’ like rhinestones glued to my ass.”

“You’re welcome, Taro,” Mina said sweetly. “You’ll find a little dazzle keeps you feeling fresh.”

Izuku hugged her tightly, and they both joked about the tracksuit’s potential. And before either groom could comment further, Momo and Jirou slipped in beside them. Momo wrapped both men in a warm, friendly hug.

“It’s so nice to all be reunited!” Momo said cheerily. “We didn’t think we’d ever hear from you two again after you left the Paradise Crew group chat. But I guess it makes sense why. You two relocated all the way to Singapore! What a big move!”

“Sorry for the disappearance,” Katsuki laughed. “We’ll make it up to you and host some time for the holidays. We just had to make sure we got our wrinkles worked out.”

“Yeah,” Izuku added. “We really wanted a fresh start after Okinawa. And moving was probably the best decision we made.”

“Aw,” Jirou said in a sweet tone. “It sounds like you two took up the couples’ counseling suggestion. You seem much better in tune with each other now.”

Izuku and Katsuki laughed awkwardly, exchanging quick sideways glances.

“Yup,” Katsuki said. “Counseling has really helped us sort out all our problems.”

“We do have a really great therapist,” Izuku quickly offered. “She’s really amazing at helping Taro get in touch with his emotions more, and she’s been helping me speak up more for myself.”

Instantly, Momo’s eyes lit up, absolutely filled with glee. She clasped her hands together and said, “I love to hear that! I can see the effort you guys put in is really coming through. You two are absolutely glowing!”

Then, right on cue, Shouto and Inasa approached. Inasa boomed congratulations so loud it nearly rattled the lights above. Following him up, Shouto offered a cooler, but no less sincere smile.

“Congratulations on your re-marriage,” Shouto teased. He raised his spicy Paloma to them and happily gestured at the dancing crowd. “I have to say, you two know a great group of people. The speeches tonight were, how did you put it, Inasa?”

“Tear-jerking!” Inasa bellowed proudly.

Shouto nodded. “Yes, tear-jerking. And some others were…*interesting*.”

Katsuki stiffly laughed. “Sorry about that. Our friends are a handful.”

“A good problem to have.” Shouto grinned. “But if you don’t mind my asking, I do have a more personal question.”

“Ask away,” Izuku replied with a welcoming smile.

“What made you decide to marry again?” Shouto asked. “You guys didn’t get divorced or something, did you?”

Izuku easily took the lead. “I got the idea from Mina that night we all got wasted. I couldn’t stop thinking about what she said that night, and I thought it was so beautiful.” He turned to Katsuki and stared up at him with lovesick eyes. “I would marry my Taro a thousand times over.”

Mina clapped dramatically. “Really?! You liked my idea?!”

“We did,” Izuku replied, beaming at her. “We thought it was so romantic and decided it’s something we should do.”

Mina preened. She immediately then lifted her left hand to show off a glimmering stack of six wedding rings to the group. Everyone was immediately awestruck by the different metals, shapes, and gemstones that fit together flawlessly.

“Damn,” Katsuki said. He whistled at the myriad of diamonds. “Talk about a tower of commitment.”

“We’ve gotten married twelve times,” Mina declared proudly. “Ei gives me a new ring every ceremony.”

Eijiro slid an arm around her waist and grinned. “We have another scheduled for two years out. For our thirteenth wedding, you’re all invited!”

The circle erupted in laughter.

The night continued with the music staying on an upbeat string of bops. Katsuki danced his heart away with his darling as their friends and family danced too.

People drifted toward the bar for refills, weaving through pockets of laughter as the night deepened. Everyone’s dazzling outfits caught the light, sequins winking like scattered stars. Katsuki let himself slip into the rhythm of it all. He moved in a state of flow with his palm resting on the small of Izuku’s back as they danced together.

It didn’t take long for the Midnight Sento crew to approach them. They were all practically glowing with radiant smiles and lambent attire.

Nemuri was stunning in her lavender silk dress. But the biggest surprise to Katsuki was Takeyama, who was holding her hand. Katsuki slyly smirked at Nemuri, who winked at him and pulled Takeyama closer. Behind them, Ryuko followed. She was sweating from dancing, and Sekijiro was accompanied by a woman whom they’ve never seen.

She was tall, elegant and possessed the kind of smile that could charm even someone as jaded as Aizawa.

“I have to say, Sekijiro refuses to shut up about you,” she teased, offering both men a hand to shake. “I’m Noriko, Sekijiro’s partner!”

“Ah, so glad to put a face to the name,” Izuku replied, shaking her hand with enthusiasm. “So glad to have you here with us to celebrate!”

“I have to say,” Katsuki added with a charming smile. “Sekijiro’s cooking is really good. I haven’t been able to replicate that lumpia that he cooked for us. No joke, I swear I daydream about it all the damn time.”

“It’s a secret recipe!” Sekijiro laughed, full and hearty. He clamped a hand on Katsuki’s shoulder. “Please, you have to come stay with us sometime in the Philippines. I’ll make sure to cook it every day for you.”

“Careful,” Katsuki warned with good-natured arrogance. “I’m the kind of man who actually takes people up on things.”

“Excellent,” Sekijiro replied, overly delighted. “Then we’ll have to get you a bed ready!”

The group drifted into more chatter. Nemuri hugged Izuku so tight it hurt, and Takeyama and Ryuko congratulated them on the beautiful wedding.

As the group drifted, another tide of dances and loud well-wishes swept them away. Katsuki and Izuku became pressed together in a circle full of cheers, and at some point, his damn knuckle-headed friends got drunk enough to lift them up in chairs. Much to Katsuki's surprise, they succeeded. He and Izuku laughed in both terror and excitement as M-Unit lifted them in the middle of the dance circle.

When the crowd settled down slightly again, the newlyweds found a small, quiet corner away from the drunken pandemonium. They laughed to themselves as they watched Aizawa loosen his tie and shimmy his shoulders.

"I hope someone is recording this," Katsuki snickered. "Oh, this is fucking priceless."

Small, innocent footsteps came up behind them.

They both turned when the person came close, and to their surprise, Ochako stood a few paces away. She was clutching a tiny purse to her chest, and her innocent, dove-like eyes were filled with astonishment. She drank in the sight of Izuku, and gradually, Izuku's smile fell into a heavier emotion. Both of their faces filled with overwhelming relief as they both stepped forward.

Katsuki's heart melted as they collided in an embrace. Izuku folded himself into her arms, and his own circled her. They held each other there, and when they both pulled back, everything felt calmer.

Ochako broke the silence first. She laughed through her tears and quickly wiped them away.

"I'm so happy you're safe," she said with a grin. "I couldn't believe it when I got the letter in the mail. Izuku, you look so handsome, and you're smiling. This all feels like some sort of dream."

Izuku's smile spread wider. "We have to catch up. There's a lot I left out of my letter. But I'm so happy to see you're doing well too. I was so worried about you."

"Good thing we have each other's numbers now. I'm going to be calling you all the time."

Ochako turned to Katsuki then, and instantaneously, he straightened. His hands dropped casually into his pockets, and his posture eased to show his full attention.

"It's really nice to meet you, Katsuki," she offered with a small, nervous bow of her head. "I've heard so much about you that it sort of feels like I already met you? I hope that isn't too weird!"

Katsuki bowed respectfully too. "Same to you. Izuku told me everything." He smiled admiringly. "Thank you for being Izuku's friend when he needed someone the most. And also thank you for…"

Carefully, Katsuki glanced around. To his relief, everyone was distracted on the dance floor getting extra drinks as Denki stole the show in the middle of a dance-off with Katsuma.

Katsuki dropped his voice below a whisper and said, “Thank you for getting Izuku that anti-venom. I wish there was a way to repay you. If there’s anything you need, let me know and I’ll do my hardest to make it happen.”

Ochako’s eyes stretched, and she shook her head vigorously with her hands up.

“Oh, that’s not necessary!” She laughed nervously. “You don’t owe me anything. The jewelry Izuku gave me was enough money to safely move my family and cut all our ties with the Yakuza. If anything, I’m indebted to you two. But honestly, I’m simply overjoyed he’s alive, and I’m glad he’s living out his dreams.”

“Ochako, you have to come visit us sometime,” Izuku then said. Bubbly enthusiasm lifted his voice. “It would be really wonderful if you stayed with us for a week. We can show you around Singapore, and I would love for you to get to know my little brother, Katsuma. It would be really nice to reconnect fully.”

“I’d love that,” Ochako replied. “Tell me when, and I’ll make it work!”

And from there, the night continued with good vibes.

Izuku and Ochako bonded further, and it was as if no years had ever divided them. Katsuki could tell that it was going to be a friendship for the ages, and he was glad Izuku had found someone like her in all the mess.

Eventually, they rejoined their friends on the dance floor. And soon after, they let themselves be carried by the gaudy pop music. Katsuki danced as if it would be his last night on earth, and grinned every time someone’s camera flashed bright in his face.

He wasn’t sure when the hours began slipping through his fingers.

Maybe it was during Izuku’s silly laugh against his shoulder. Or perhaps it was when Katsuma tugged Shinsou into an impromptu dance that made everyone cheer. But somewhere between the smiles, the music, and the delight of existing together in the same lifetime, the evening transformed into a hell of a night to remember.

☽ ☽ ☽

When the night thinned and the last of the music faded, the evening closed out.

The background sound of the city echoed behind them as their guests drifted to the elevators. The rooftop garden emptied by steady degrees. First, the embraces, then the final congratulations. It kept going until at last they were all ushered gently through the glass doors down to the street level.

As they walked outside, Katsuki laced his fingers with Izuku’s.

He was prepared to say his last farewells to his friends when suddenly the crowd in front of them slowed. A collective whisper rose, spiking confusion.

Katsuki was about to ask what was wrong, but then the crowd parted for them.

He stopped in his tracks.

Waiting at the curb was a small white buggy. It was polished to a perfect glossy luster and decorated with hundreds of white orchids. A string of tin bells hung in looping arcs across the back, and on its rear was a sign written in cursive font: *Just Married*.

A driver stood by the open door, and stacked neatly behind him were two pieces of luggage.

Izuku stammered, eyes going as big as moons.

“Kacchan,” he whispered only for him to hear. “Did you get us a car?”

“No, this wasn’t me,” Katsuki muttered, equally floored.

Suddenly, Nana stepped forward with a guilty smile. Aizawa stood beside her with his hands buried in his pants pockets. He was trying, and really fucking failing, to look like he wasn’t pleased with himself.

“Surprise!” Nana said, full of playfulness. “It wouldn’t be a wedding if you didn’t have a honeymoon to go with it! You two are heading straight to the airport now.”

Katsuki and Izuku were taken aback.

Quickly, Izuku opened his mouth to retort, but Aizawa beat him to the punch.

“It’s already a done deal. We conspired with your little brother,” Aizawa explained with a wink to the kid. Katsuma cheerfully laughed and gave a thumbs up. “This was all his idea, by the way. He got a hold of the phone and told us you two were skipping out on a destination honeymoon in place of a staycation because you didn’t want to leave him alone.”

“We thought it would be better to stay around,” Izuku tried to explain, still in shock. “We don’t have anyone to babysit—”

“—Nana says she’ll stay with me!” Katsuma chimed happily. He skipped up to the elder woman and hugged her side. He smiled up at her with the sweetest expression in his eyes. “I really want to spend time with her too. I’ve missed her a lot!”

Nana smiled and wrapped an arm around Katsuma. “We got it covered. You two go relax on a beach.”

Katsuki frowned. “But hold on, we don’t have our stuff—”

“Oh my god,” Monoma groaned loudly. He dramatically shoved Katsuki and Izuku toward the car. “Please, you two *go*. Everything is packed for you. Your kid nabbed everything while you two were fussing over hairspray brands this morning.”

Izuku whipped his head towards Katsuma. “Is that true?”

“It is,” Katsuma responded proudly. “All your things are packed in the bags. I triple-checked, and then Aizawa double-checked!”

“The driver has the flight tickets,” Aizawa clarified. “Wallets, keys, and passports are in the smaller suitcase along with the resort itinerary.”

Katsuma then scurried up to Katsuki and tugged at the hem of his blazer. He pulled Katsuki down to his height and quietly whispered in his ear, “Don’t worry, I put your surprise in the big bag! It’s wrapped and everything.”

Katsuki raised a brow at Katsuma. “You sneaky little brat.”

“Now enough fussing,” Monoma said. “The flight leaves in two hours. You need to enjoy a proper honeymoon that doesn’t involve me and Shinsou kicking in the door.”

Shinsou chuckled slightly. “Yeah. You two earned it.”

Katsuki was speechless. He looked around, and everyone was grinning. His smile twitched into a reluctant but amused smirk.

“I can’t believe you guys are forcing us on vacation,” Katsuki said. “You’ve all teamed up against us.”

“Damn right we have,” Denki snickered. “Now go have a good time!”

Katsuki glanced at Izuku, who was processing the shock too. They squeezed each other’s hands and began hugging all their guests, one by one. The couple said goodbye and exchanged numbers with the people in their lives they would soon see again.

They walked towards the buggy and, like gentle snow, small tiny petals rained down on them. Katsuki grinned as he peered back and saw everyone surprise them with more and more petals. Roses, orchids and carnations floated in the air before landing in their hair, their clothes, and across the pavement at their feet as they walked to the car.

Katsuki helped Izuku climb into the back seat and joined him with a matching smile.

They turned toward their people one last time.

Katsuma was at the very front, held gently by Nana. He waved both hands with unrestrained enthusiasm, then puckered his lips and blew them an exaggerated kiss. Izuku wiped a tear with the back of his wrist and blew a kiss back. Katsuki followed suit, and their little boy cackled with delight.

The driver closed their door, stepped around, and settled into the front seat.

Outside the window, Sero lifted an arm high. Denki whistled. Miruko gave a peace sign. Aizawa offered a subtle nod that somehow felt louder than all the rest. Ochako waved lovingly, while behind her everyone else saw them off.

It was a send-off drenched in love.

The buggy pulled away from the curb with an electric purr. Izuku leaned into Katsuki’s shoulder with their hands entwined. Along the way, their eternity rings caught the passing

streetlights with sharp shimmers.

And behind them, the ‘Just Married’ sign swung gently.

☽ ☽ ☾ ☾

Izuku sighed happily as he kicked his legs across Katsuki’s lap.

He leaned his head back as the sun beat down on his skin, soaking in all the rays. He adjusted his large sunhat on his head once more before taking a small, delighted sip of his Piña colada.

“You’ve had three of those things now,” Katsuki said without looking up from the romance novel he was nose deep in. He rested a hand on Izuku’s leg and traced little hearts against his shin. “Do you want another? I could use a refill too.”

Izuku smiled at his husband. “Let’s get one before we head back to our suite. I want to soak in the views a little more.”

Katsuki turned to him with crinkled eyes. “Take your time, no rush at all.”

Izuku hummed as he leaned back some more. He glanced around at the beach they were on, loving the sight before him. Lazy palm trees swayed in the wind beside the clear blue Visayan Sea. Izuku listened to the sound of seagulls as the wind blew harder.

He looked up at their colorful umbrellas and then returned his gaze to his husband. In that exact moment, Katsuki’s mouth tugged upwards on the side as if something in the book amused him. Izuku then appreciated the way sunlight caught his beautiful blond hair. It always magically turned each strand into a stroke of gold leaf.

They finished their drinks unhurriedly, then finally rose from their sun-beds.

They strolled hand in hand across the warm sand toward the bar for one last round. The bartender recognized them by now and grinned. He slid over two Piña coladas decorated with bright slices of pineapple and miniature pink umbrellas.

From there, the day was a mesh of sun, sea, and smiles.

They hiked. They relaxed.

They even did couples’ yoga in the tracksuits Mina and Eijiro gifted to them.

And through it all, Izuku somehow fell deeper in love.

Maybe it was because with every moment he was reminded why he adored his husband so much. Katsuki always took into account what he said, and as always treated him like an equal. It was nice being in a relationship where mutual respect was the foundation. And Izuku always made sure to return the same respect too. It was a lovely balance.

When the day was at its end, they retired to the honeymoon suite.

Izuku plopped down on the bed, red rose petals fluttering with the light bounce.

“Okay,” he laughed. “I’m mad at Katsuma for pulling one over on us, but he had a great idea.”

“Yeah, that kid is too smart for his own good,” Katsuki laughed too. “But I’ll give him a big thanks when we get back.”

Izuku sighed into the fluffy white comforter. He curled into it with a content hum and ran his fingers across the soft, floral scented sheets.

As Izuku snuggled into the bed, he curiously eyed the vinyl record player next to the nightstand. When they first arrived, Katsuki requested it at the front desk. Originally, Izuku didn’t think much of it because he was so shocked Nana had booked such a nice resort. But now, he wondered why *had* Katsuki asked for it?

Right as he was about to inquire, Katsuki cleared his throat.

Izuku lifted his head and turned.

His heart stuttered.

Katsuki was standing in front of him, holding a giant white box with a viridian bow.

“Surprise,” Katsuki said with a toothy grin. “I know we already exchanged gifts, but I couldn’t resist getting you a second one.”

Izuku laughed, stunned. “Kacchan, you didn’t need to do that.”

“I know, but I wanted to. This one is different.”

He handed Izuku the box, and they smiled sweetly at each other. They sat down on the edge of the bed together, red rose petals all around them. With a flick of his hand, Izuku carefully unfurled the bow and opened the box up. And when he saw what was sitting inside, the world around him came to a halt.

Inside the box on a velvet cushion was a violin. It was white and a perfect replica of the one Souta had given him all those years ago. He took it in his hands as if it was calling to him, mesmerised. His eyes widened by the second as he looked at all the engravings and found a tiny etching that held his and Katsuki’s names along the side.

“Kacchan?” Izuku whispered in disbelief, taken aback. “Where did you get this from?”

“I got it specially made at that instrument shop in the city,” Katsuki said with a smile. “I wanted to give you this when it was only the two of us.”

Izuku turned the violin over in his hands. The surface shone enough that Izuku could see a faint reflection of his eyes. He blinked several times, trying to process what he was looking at. It was as if Katsuki had reached back in time and plucked it clean from the younger version of himself.

“Wow,” Izuku said in wonder. “You’re still finding ways to surprise me, even after all this time. Thank you, Kacchan. This is so thoughtful.”

“Don’t thank me yet,” Katsuki said smugly. “Lucky you, the surprise isn’t done yet.”

Izuku became even more perplexed as Katsuki lifted the velvet cushion in the box. Hiding underneath were two more concealed items. One was a folded sheet of parchment, and the other was a brand new vinyl with the name obscured. Katsuki turned to him with a nervous, loving smile as he handed Izuku the cream-colored paper.

Izuku unfolded it, and bars of music appeared before him.

The sheet music was handwritten in neat, meticulous ink. It was done in a way that only his detail-oriented husband could execute. And beneath the last measure, a tiny note in the corner read: *For the one who taught me how to love, my darling.*

Katsuki reached up and brushed a thumb beneath Izuku’s eye even before a tear could fall.

“I’ve been working on it since we first moved,” Katsuki explained. “I wrote it because I wanted to show how excited I am for all the years we have to come. And if you’re comfortable with it, I’d love for you to perform it for the next city symphony showcase.”

“I’d love that,” Izuku whispered as he stared at the notes on the page. “You’re too good to me, Kacchan. This is so beautiful.”

“You haven’t even heard it yet,” Katsuki reminded him. He took the record from its sleeve and walked up to the vinyl record player. “I had the city symphony record the other sections, minus the violin. So that way, you can play along any time you want.”

Izuku smiled and then laughed. “You thought of everything.”

“For you, of course I did,” Katsuki replied easily.

He brought the needle over the record and let the music flow. With a smile, he sat down next to Izuku on the bed.

“Go on. Play for me, darling.”

Izuku nodded and placed the sheets down between him and Katsuki. He lifted the violin, and the weight settled naturally against his shoulder. Izuku exhaled as if he’d just come home after a long journey.

And with a smile, he raised the bow and performed for his lover.

The first note fluttered into the air like a dove. Then another came. Then a long, sweeping phrase curled through the suite like a graceful ribbon of silver light. Izuku closed his eyes, allowing the melody to transport him. He felt Katsuki beside him, ushering him through a world that felt half memory and half a beautiful daydream.

All at once, the surrounding room transformed.

Izuku saw soft, romantic visions woven into each rising phrase. He saw himself and Katsuki as children racing through sunlit streets. He heard their giggles and felt the snowflakes against his cheeks. He saw them as teenagers, encircling one another with an intensity sharp enough to wound. Then he saw them as broken men learning gentleness again, reaching, faltering, and forgiving.

The music swelled.

And suddenly they were dancing.

They waltzed through all the hurt, the love, and the pain. Their feet twirled above the years, drifting as if the melody itself was taking them through time.

Together, he and Katsuki pirouetted through all the different versions of themselves alongside the musical notes. They laughed. They fought. They reconciled and moved together like two rivers constantly running beside each other for eternity, simply two souls in a seamless choreography of the heart.

Above the peak of the song, they balanced on the lines of life and fate, brushing past stardust along their way. Then, as the last notes lengthened, the two husbands rested together upon a cloud painted in the bright blue sky. Everything around them became weightless as they floated in each other's arms. Izuku leaned into Katsuki, and his heart synced to the last fading chords.

And when the final note fell, the vision felt like it was still around them. Izuku could have sworn he was in a cloud, laying right beside his husband. He glanced to his side, and his heart warmed.

Katsuki was admiring him like a poet who'd finally found the missing metaphor that made his poem whole.

"Perfect," Katsuki whispered. "You're still the best violinist I know."

Izuku smiled. "I think that was the most beautiful piece of music I've ever heard. You really have a way with music that's unmatched."

"Couldn't have done it without such a great muse."

Izuku lowered the violin. He placed it on his lap as he turned his body to the one he loved. He stared at the man before him: his fated husband, his best friend, and the one person who chased him through hell again and again and again to always find him.

"What's the title, Kacchan?"

Katsuki's fingertips brushed Izuku's cheek.

"Lovebirds in Repose."

⋆.* . ☄ Fin ☄. *. ⋆

Chapter End Notes

And that's a wrap!!

I genuinely can't believe it's over. As I'm posting this, I am ugly crying with tears streaming down my face. I'm not a person who usually cries either, so this is really tough for me. It's something about this fic that has been beating the shit out of my heart strings ever since chapter 48. It caught me super off guard and made me really reflect on why that is. And as I did, I realized the reason is because I am just so happy I got to experience writing this story with you all and I'm extremely sad the experience of live updating is at an end.

So, in a really cheesy ramble, I want say thank you to everyone for reading along and coming this far with me on this.
I had no intensions of this story getting this long (or even having any eyes on it because it was so messy and crazy). But I can not expression how truly touched, humbled, and grateful I am that I got to write this story with all of you.

Yes :) *with* you.

I know that is very cheesy to say, but it's true. Without the support of those who read while this was an ongoing process, I would have never completed a passion project this massive.
This fic has been with me through so many ups and downs in my life. From when I first started writing it after graduating my Masters in a global pandemic in 2020, to making my first big move out my parent's home. It's also been with me through some really hard times like deaths in the family, friendship break ups, and getting wrongfully fired (lol to the last one).

But more importantly, its been with me through the good times as well. While writing this I made new life long friends and landed my actual dream job after I got let go. This fic has been a staple in my life and heart.

But what I loved most this experience was the readers!

While writing this fic, I was reminded every step of the way that this is what I love most about fan fiction & fandom: the community it brings. Writing this story over the last five years with everyone reading along chapter by chapter really help me stay happy, sane, and creative.

I truly can't imagine having done it without you guys.

Commenters and silent readers alike, you all really are great. And this is why I love art so much, because of the connections it brings. Pieces of art like this have the ability to bring together people who might never cross paths and lets us bond over something we care about. I enjoyed writing every single last word of this fic and I equally enjoyed

reading every comment, scream and even watching tiktoks about it (Yes, I see them! I don't have a fanfic tiktok account but my friends send them to me when they stumble upon them!)

I also made so so many great friends through this fic! Some of my closet friends I gained from writing this fic back in 2021, because they were reading along and had sent me really kind, heartfelt messages. On top of that, I was so lucky to get up every day genuinely excited to write and brainstorm for last five years! It's been such a lovely highlight of my life that had kept me grounded.

This is a bit of an emotional ramble, but I am just very emotional right now :') Its probably hitting hard because the anime ends tomorrow as well. I honestly had no plans for this story to end in sync with the anime, but it worked out that way and it seems like fate might've had a hand in that. What a weird way for life to come at ya lol But what I guess I'm trying to say is, thank you all ♥ From the bottom of my heart. I'm so glad you all enjoyed reading as much as I loved creating.

I do have plans on writing a bonus chapter that covers the events through Tomura's POV that I will add later! I had been writing his POV along side all the main events to make sure his motivation kept in sync with his actions. But For now I am going to take a relaxing break, reset, and re-read the whole story and comments with a smile.

I hope you all have have great rest of your day and happy upcoming new year :')

🧡💚🧡💚🧡💚🧡💚

End Notes

My Twitter
Deathly Beautiful Spotify Playlist

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!